



CULTIVATION ONLINE

MyLittleBrother

Chapter 1 - Cultivation Online

"Brother! I got the game you wanted!" The teenager said cheerfully next to the young man laying on the bed. In her grasp was a large helmet that looked like a bike helmet, but with more of a sci-fi look.

The young man's eyes were closed, seemingly asleep, but the girl continued to speak: "Here, let me help you put it on..."

The girl climbed on the large bed that could fit an entire family of four, and she lifted his head, putting the helmet she had prepared on his head.

"Thank you..." The young man finally spoke in a hoarse voice after she gently laid his head back down.

The girl smiled, tenderly caressing his hair so it wouldn't bother him.
"Brother, although I will be busy with school this week, next week for sure, I will play with you."

"Un..."

"I will come back later, so until then, have fun!" After those words, she went to touch the button on the side of the helmet and waited a few moments before leaving the young man alone.

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It only took a few seconds after the button was pressed for the young man's body in the real world to fall into a state similar to slumber. He could no longer smell the aroma that was unique to his room or feel the weight of the blanket pressing down on his body. Instead, he could feel himself standing, something he didn't have the opportunity to experience for many years.

The world before him was mostly black, like the night sky without stars, and he could see white numbers floating above him, slowly counting down.

«10:01»

«10:00»

«09:59»

"I can see... I can feel my limbs... I... am no longer blind or a cripple..." The young man broke down in this darkness, becoming emotional and falling to his knees.

He was born with an incurable illness that left him blind at the age of 7 and crippled at the age of 13. He is now 18 years old, and for the past 5 years he would lay in his bed, unable to do anything else besides just laying there; it was a gruesome and unimaginable life that one wouldn't even dare to imagine themselves in.

However, for this young man who has spent more than half of his life living in a world void of light, he was able to continue living without giving in to despair because of his caring younger sister, who supported him every day without any complaints.

"So this is the world's first VRMMORPG with 100% immersion, huh."

When he first heard of the game from his younger sister, he almost couldn't believe it.

A game that operates inside the mind of the individual, allowing that person to live in another world without the need to move a single limb — who would believe that such an incredible and advanced technology could exist? Not to mention that this high-tech technology was announced to be affordable enough for even the most common families to enjoy.

It was unimaginable at first, but experiencing it firsthand, the young man can only believe it.

«02:19»

«02:18»

The countdown continued to lower as the young man tries to familiarize himself with the feeling of moving his limbs. Although it was difficult at first, even tripping after every few steps, he gradually became familiarized with his body again.

«00:03»

«00:02»

«00:01»

«00:00»

«Welcome to Cultivation Online!»

As the system's notice appeared, the black space quickly brightened, becoming a bright white room. And right before the young man, a crack appeared out of thin air, looking like a glass window being cracked.

Crack. Crack. Crack...

The crack grew larger and larger — until it was large enough for an adult to fit.

Suddenly, the large crack broke apart entirely, revealing the darkness behind it, and a beautiful woman with a graceful and elegant body slowly walked out from within the cracked space, looking like a goddess appearing from another world.

"This is..." The young man could only watch in a daze as the beautiful woman who just came out of the cracked space began looking at him from top to bottom with a seemingly cold expression on her otherworldly face. Dressed in unfamiliar red and golden robes, her figure was supple and graceful. Her facial features are sharp, symmetrical, and peerless. All in all, she looked like an otherworldly goddess. However, despite all of her perfect features, her gaze was anything but friendly.

She stared at him with her golden eyes that overflowed with a feeling of dominance, and her aura radiated with a tyrannical power that the young man cannot comprehend.

"Mortal, place your hand on this." The beauty spoke to him with a cold voice that was fitting for a ruler, and the young man watched as she pulled out a crystal ball from thin air.

"Okay." Believing that she was an NPC, the young man followed her instructions and placed his hand on the crystal ball without thinking about it too much, and words began appearing inside the crystal ball.

Name: ???

Cultivation: None

Legacy: None

Bloodline: None

Physique: Heaven Refining Physique

Physical Strength: 34

Mental Strength: 275

Soul Strength: 1,210

Physical Defense: 10

Mental Defense: 1,121

"?!?!" The beauty's expression suddenly changed upon seeing the information in the crystal ball, her clear eyes filled with disbelief.

"Heaven Refining Physique!" Her hands trembled along with the crystal ball in her grasp. "Not to mention his Soul Strength is at the rank of Spirit Warrior despite being only a mortal with no cultivation — No, that is nothing when compared to his physique!"

The beauty has never been this shocked before, even to the point of her body trembling.

"Is something wrong?" The young man asked her upon seeing her silence and excited expression.

She lifted her head to look at him, thinking to herself: 'I must rope him into joining my faction before the others find him...'

"What is your name?" she asked him with a serious expression.

"You can call me Yuan."

"Take this token and keep it with you until we meet next time." The beauty retrieved a jade medallion from thin air and suddenly tossed it to him. "I don't have much time left here. Make sure you don't lose the token, I will see you again."

"Huh? Wait, I have some..." Before Yuan can even ask her any questions, the beauty walked back into the cracked hole, disappearing alongside the crack in the air.

"What an odd NPC. What should I do now?" He looked around the empty place.

«Character evaluation complete. Teleportation will occur in 10 seconds.»

«00:02»

«00:01»

As the timer reached zero, Yuan's vision suddenly twisted, giving him a slight headache. When he blinked and opened his eyes, he found himself on some kind of stage where many people that wore the same white robe as him were gathered in a spacious area.

"This is... Cultivation Online?" His eyes widen when he saw mountains floating in the sky above the clouds and what appeared to be houses built on these floating mountains.

"Welcome, Mortals! I am Elder Song, in charge of making sure that before you all leave this place and adventure this vast world that you will have a goal of what you want to do here set in your mind." An old man in blue robes suddenly greeted everybody with a booming voice, causing everybody there to look above them.

"He's flying! He is really flying while standing on that sword!" The people exclaimed the obvious.

Elder Song smiled and said: "I will answer your questions later, but first, let me explain to you about this world — the world of Cultivation."

"First and foremost, this is the Heavenly Continent, and we are currently at Mountain #96. Before you were transported here, everyone should have met a representative from our world that gave you an evaluation. That is your character status; it tells you almost everything about yourself."

"We will start with the basics. In this world, humans and monsters cultivate their bodies and mind with Spirit Qi that allows them to obtain supernatural powers. We call people like them Cultivators, and the higher the cultivation you reach, the stronger you will be in this world. Legacy and Bloodlines are special features that can be obtained later on if you are fortunate enough. As for Physique, everyone here should have one. Whether or not it is useless, this will tell you."

Elder Song waved his long sleeves and thousands of talisman flew towards the people there.

"Activate it with your thoughts," said Elder Song.

The crowd followed his instruction, and loud exclamations resounded soon afterward.

"It says that I have an Earth-ranked Physique! What does that mean?"

Elder Song looked at the young man who just spoke and said to him, "There is a one in ten thousand chances one is born with an Earth-rank Physique. Congratulations. You are what we call 'talented'."

"Elder, how many ranks of Physiques are there?"

"The rank for Physiques consists of Mortal, Earth, Heaven, and Divine."

"Elder, what does having a Mortal-rank Physique mean, and what is the difference between the ranks?"

Elder Song remained silent for a moment, before speaking with a grin, "Having a Mortal Physique means you are only ordinary, but having an Earth Physique means you are talented. The difference is obvious — you are naturally inferior to those who have a better physique than you! The more talented you are, the easier it will be for you as a Cultivator!"

His words caused many faces to sink, especially those with a Mortal Physique.

"Can our Physiques be changed?" Someone suddenly asked.

"Physiques can be changed, but the process is a long and painful one, so most people just accept their fate."

The people sighed in relief after hearing that their Mortal Physique can be changed.

"Does anyone here happen to have a Divine rank Physique?" Elder Song's eyes flickered with expectation, but when nobody replied to his question the light in his eyes dimmed.

'The chances of someone having a Divine Physique is one in a hundred million, a genius above genius that knows no equal, so it isn't surprising that such a prodigy wouldn't appear amongst a mere thousand people.' He shook his head inwardly.

"Elder, I have a Heaven-ranked Physique." An individual suddenly said out loud, causing everybody there to look at him.

"Hoh? The chances of a Heaven Physique appearing is one in a million. You are a very fortunate one, young genius. What is your name?"

"My name is Shen Ming," replied the handsome young man.

"Shen Ming? Isn't he the eldest son of Shen Li, the CEO of Royal Entertainment?"

Some people there recognized the handsome young man whose face looked exactly the same as he does in real life.

"Did you receive something from the representative who did your evaluation?" Elder Song asked him with great interest.

"Yes, I did." Shen Ming did not hide that fact and told him the truth. "I received this pouch from the representative."

"Oho... That is a storage pouch used to store items, there may be a few things in there that could benefit you. However, only cultivators are capable of using it. Additionally, if you can meet the person who gave you that gift again, they might even recruit you as a disciple for their Sect."

"Sect? You mean like guilds?"

"A Sect is a place created by one or a group of people for the purpose of nurturing its disciples to become powerful Cultivators — a school for Cultivators, basically." Elder Song briefly explained. "Is that it? Does nobody else have a Heaven Physique?"

After a moment of silence, Elder Song shook his head and thought to himself, 'What a pity that there is only one person out of the thousands here worth investing in. But even then, I don't know who had given him that storage pouch. It'd be rude of me if I were to steal away their target, and I might even offend someone I cannot afford to offend.'

"I have one question for everybody here before I let you leave... What do you desire to achieve in this world? Strength? Status? Wealth? Handsome men? Beautiful women? Tell me, Mortals from another world!"

"I want to fly like you!"

"I wish for power!"

"I want to be famous!"

"I want enough money to make a mountain!"

"I want to walk around with beautiful women in both my arms!"

"I want handsome men to pamper me!"

Elder Song smiled upon hearing the masses' desires. "If you want to survive in a world such as this, then you must have power! In this world, the strong rules the weak! Wealth and fame will naturally come if you are strong! People will flock to you if you are strong! Remember my words, young ones — this world looks down on the weak and the inferior, respecting only the strong! Having strength means you have everything!"

"Who do you think have the most power in this world?" Elder Song glanced at the people below with a narrowed gaze, sending chills down their spine.

"Cultivators! We, Cultivators, are a symbol of power, wealth, fame, and respect — we are the rule of this world!"

"Cultivators, is that some sort of class?" The people wondered.

"Elder, how do I become a Cultivator?"

Elder Song smiled. "It's simple, really." He suddenly waved his sleeves, and thousands of glowing orbs appeared out of the blue and flew towards the people and directly at their forehead, submerging into their brain.

"I have just given you all the method to cultivate. It is now up to you to decide whether you want to cultivate or remain as a mortal." Elder Song waved his sleeves again, and four portals appear not too far away from the group. "Each portal represents a Continent. In this world, we have Four Great Continents not including this Heavenly Continent. Once you step inside, it will take you to a place within one of these Four Great Continents randomly, but even I will not know exactly where you'll land so it is up to your fate."

«You have learned: Basic Qi Gathering Technique»

«Rank: Mortal»

«Mastery Level: 1»

«Description: Absorbs 1 Qi every second. Can only be activated when sitting in the lotus position.»

"Now, scram. I have spent too much of my precious time dealing with you mortals. You will learn more about this world as you travel. Even if I use the remaining of my longevity, I won't be able to explain to you everything about this world."

With another wave of his sleeve, everybody there began flying towards the portal as though they were being pulled towards them.

"Ahhhhh!!!"

Shocked cries resounded, and those who entered the portal would soon appear in this vast and unknown world at random.

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After being thrown into the portal, Yuan felt the slight dizziness again, and before he was aware, he was in the middle of a forest.

"Where is this? Is there a map I can use?"

Suddenly, a large map with four large continents separated by water appears before him.

"Eastern Continent?" That was the only information he could gather from the map. Everything else was blacked out.

Yuan tilted his head to look at the bright sky and sighed. "I didn't get to ask him about my Physique. That old man said that there only exist four ranks of Physiques: Mortal, Earth, Heaven, and Divine, so why does my Physique not belong to any one of these four ranks? Do I have a special body?"

In his grasp was a talisman with the following words on it:

«Heaven Refining Physique»

«Rank: Celestial»

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Chapter 2 - Mysterious Little Girl

"Character status." Yuan activated the system command through his mind as he did with the talisman.

Name: Yuan

Cultivation: None

Legacy: None

Bloodline: None

Physique: Heaven Refining Physique

Physical Strength: 34

Mental Strength: 275

Soul Strength: 1,210

Physical Defense: 10

Mental Defense: 1,121

"What do these stats do?" He pondered and pondered, but alas, without a guide or someone to teach him, he was clueless. "From what the creators of this game said, there will be no guides or manuals, leaving us, the players, to learn about this game for ourselves..."

"There should be a leveling system in these types of games, but where is the experience bar? What is my level? This feels more like reality than playing a game." Yuan opened and closed his hands into a fist.

Bang!

Suddenly, he punched a nearby tree.

"Ah! It really hurts! Does it hurt because this game is sending pain signals to my brain, making it believe that I am actually hitting a real tree? That's... scary no matter how I think about it."

What if he got stabbed by a sword? What would that feel like? He didn't want to think about it.

"Umm... excuse me, the brother over there..." A sweet voice suddenly resounded behind Yuan, making him turn his head.

"Huh?"

Standing right behind him was a cute little girl in red robes who looked to be around 10 years old, hugging a red ball in one arm and a book in the other.

'How did she get so close behind me without making a single sound? I didn't even notice her presence! And what is such a young girl doing here, in the middle of nowhere? Perhaps there is a city nearby?' Yuan became curious.

"Are you an NPC or a Player?" He asked her, who tilted her head sideways with a puzzled expression.

"NPC? Player? Xiao Hua is Xiao Hua," replied the little girl.

"So your name is Xiao Hua, huh. My name is Yuan."

"How did Brother Yuan manage to get in here?" She suddenly asked him with a curious gaze, almost like it is her first time seeing another person in her life.

"Get in here? We are outside, aren't we?"

She shook her head and said, "We are inside my family's garden."

"Huh? Garden?" Yuan looked stupefied at her answer. "This forest is your garden...?"

She nodded.

If this place that looks like a forest is her family's garden, then how big was the house itself? He couldn't imagine it. While it sounded unbelievable, it also explained why such a small girl like her would appear here.

"Sorry for intruding, but I was teleported here by some old man against my will..." He tried to explain without sounding too crazy. "I'll leave immediately, so can you tell me the way?"

But out of his expectations, the little girl shook her head. "Brother Yuan, since you are already here, why don't you play with Xiao Hua?"

"You want me to play with you?" He did not expect such a request from her.

"Xiao Hua is always alone and it is boring to play with herself."

"What about your family?"

"They are always busy and cannot play with Xiao Hua."

"Is that so..." Yuan felt sorry for her. He himself would be an outcast if it were not for his younger sister, so he knew very well what it feels like to be alone.

"Okay, this big brother will play with you!" He patted his chest with confidence. Due to his illness that left him unable to move even a limb, he did not have the leisure to play with his younger sister when she was young, so he saw this as an opportunity to experience what it would be like if he wasn't born with that illness.

"Really? You will play with Xiao Hua?" Her eyes glittered like the tiny stars in the sky, and her bright expression was adorable enough to soften the hearts of even the cruelest killers out there.

"Un. What do you want to play?"

"Then Xiao Hua will throw the ball to you, and you will throw it back, okay?" She placed the book down and showed him the ball.

"Let me get some distance... Okay, I am ready."

And without further ado, the two began playing throwing ball, and soon after, the merry laughter of a joyous little girl would echo in the forest.

While Yuan was spending his time entertaining a mysterious little girl, other Players would either be strengthening themselves or trying to gain more information about this world. Everybody rushed to surpass their friends and rivals in this new game that just came out, especially those who wish to become a professional and are required to be ahead of everybody else.

Minutes quickly turned into hours, and while everyone was grinding in their own ways, Yuan continued to play with the little girl.

'What monstrous stamina this little girl has! We have been throwing this ball back and forth for many hours, yet there is not a drop of sweat on her face! Even her small body shows no sign of fatigue!' Yuan smiled bitterly, his entire body drenched in sweat. How could he, a young man, get worn out before a little girl that's half his age while playing throwing ball? Although he has not moved a muscle for many years in the real world, this was virtual reality; he shouldn't even be sweating, let alone feeling fatigued!

"What's wrong, Brother Yuan? You do not look so good... Are you sick?" Xiao Hua's words dealt significant damage to his pride.

"No... I am... just a bit... tired..." he said in an exhausted voice.

Hearing his words, she no longer threw the ball at him. "Then do you want to take a rest before we resume?"

"You... you still want to play?"

"Un!" she nodded vigorously, nearly making him cry.

"Okay... but let me rest for a bit..."

He sits down at a nearby tree, and Xiao Hua follows him, sitting beside him.

"Where is Brother Yuan from?" she asked.

"I am from a faraway place called Earth."

"Earth?"

Seeing her glittering eyes, Yuan smiled. "Do you want to hear about my homeland? Although it is not much, I still have memories of the places I went as a child."

"Yes! I want to hear stories about this Earth!"

"Very well, then..."

Yuan began telling stories to Xiao Hua of the things he has done as a child, and she quickly became engrossed in his stories.

After an hour of nonstop storytelling, when he ran out of both breaths and stories to tell her, Xiao Hua opens the book in her grasp and spoke, "Since Brother Yuan played with Xiao Hua and even told her stories, Xiao Hua shall also tell you stories," she said. "This is Xiao Hua's gratitude to you, Brother Yuan!"

Yuan did not refuse and humbly accepted her appreciation.

However, when she began reading the book in her hands, he was surprised to find out that he wasn't able to understand a single word coming out of her mouth. It sounded more like chanting than a story!

But he didn't want to be rude to her, so he continued to listen. Soon, without being aware, he closed his eyes. After closing his eyes, he began feeling more relaxed and comfortable, almost as though he was experiencing some kind of hypnotization.

The weird chanting from Xiao Hua became less gibberish — he was beginning to comprehend her words, and information he never knew was being fed into his head. This continued for a whole hour before a sharp sound would suddenly wake Yuan from his meditative state.

«You have learned Heaven's Secret Art»

"Heaven's Secret Art...?"

Xiao Hua smiled gently upon hearing Yuan's mumble.

And suddenly, above the sky for every player to witness, a grand system notice appears.

«Player Yuan has become the world's first player to have learned a Divine-rank Skill! Congratulations!»

The announcement shocked every witness there, especially those Players at the top. The game has not even been out for a day, yet someone has managed to obtain a Divine-rank Skill already? Who was this Player 'Yuan', and what did he do to obtain it?

Chapter 3 - Becoming A Cultivator

"What's wrong, Brother Yuan?" Xiao Hua asked him, who looked dazed while staring at the sky.

"Oh, the announcement..." He pointed to the words in the sky.

"I don't see anything, though?" She said.

"Hm? You cannot see the words in the sky?"

She shook her head, prompting Yuan to ponder. 'Perhaps NPCs cannot see the game's notifications?'

—

«Heaven's Secret Art»

«Rank: Divine»

«Mastery Level: 1»

«Description: There are nine heavenly stages for Heaven's Secret Art. Each new stage will unlock a new ability.»

—

«Heaven's First Secret Art — Consuming Heaven Technique»

«Rank: Divine»

«Mastery Level: 1»

«Description: Absorbs 5 Qi per second. Can only be activated when sitting in the lotus position.»

—

"Xiao Hua, what is Qi?" Yuan decided to ask her, who he believes to have more knowledge than him regarding this world.

"Qi is the essence of this world; it is what people use to cultivate."

"Cultivate, huh. That old man had said the same... Let me try this..." he closed his eyes and positioned himself to sit in the lotus position before activating the skill.

Ding!

«You have cultivated for the first time, unlocking Qi Experience»

«5/5,000»

«10/5,000»

«15/5,000»

His Qi Experience increased by 5 for every second he cultivated. Additionally, when he activated the Consuming Heaven Technique, his breathing naturally became calm and rhythmic, and his entire body felt refreshed, almost as though it was breathing through every existing pore.

Within just a few minutes, Yuan suddenly felt his entire body explode with a cool feeling, almost like he had been thrown into a pool of cool water on a hot day.

«You have succeeded in breaking through your mortal shackles, becoming a Spirit Apprentice!»

«All stats +100»

'All I have to do is sit here and cultivate to grow stronger in this game? How boring!' Yuan ignorantly thought to himself. 'But it does feel pleasant, almost like I am relaxing in a warm bath or something of sorts.'

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Name: Yuan

Cultivation: First Level Spirit Apprentice

Legacy: None

Bloodline: None

Physique: Heaven Refining Physique

Physical Strength: 134

Mental Strength: 375

Soul Strength: 1,310

Physical Defense: 110

Mental Defense: 1,221

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"Congratulations on becoming a Cultivator, Brother Yuan." Xiao Hua said to him with a smile.

"It is all because of you, Xiao Hua. You have my gratitude."

"Then let's continue to play!" She stood up with the ball already in her hands, ready to be thrown.

Yuan smiled bitterly, but he didn't refuse and continued to play with her.

Surprisingly, when he stood up, all the fatigue he had just moments ago was gone; he had fully recovered all of his exhausted energy the moment he became a Cultivator.

The two began playing again, but the speed the ball was being thrown seemed to be at a much faster pace than previously.

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Meanwhile, the world was in turmoil from the game's first world announcement.

Rich and powerful companies in the real world began looking into this player named Yuan with hopes to find his real identity. However, it was a near-impossible task due to the way the game handled the players' privacy.

Unlike other games where one can see the players' names at glance, Cultivation Online did not have that feature. Unless the individual allows it, nobody would be able to see their name, not even their friends.

After spending many resources and time looking for Yuan, people quickly came to a realization that unless Yuan willingly revealed himself, his identity would remain unknown forever. But that alone was not enough to force these people into giving up on trying to find him.

The internet, game forums, even newspapers, people began offering real money for information on Yuan, even outright paying thousands for the person himself to reveal himself.

Virtual reality has become so deeply involved in the real world that it would not be an exaggeration to say that professional gamers and top rankers have more fame and respect than even the top celebrities in the world.

Some professional gamers, in fact, earn seven digits every month just from s alone!

In fact, even casual gamers can earn more money than people with normal jobs just by selling in-game items for real money!

With so much appeal, it would only be obvious for people to want to become a gamer where they can have fun and earn money instead of choosing work that involves labor.

Furthermore, according to last year's gaming report, at least half of the world's population is a virtual gamer!

—

After throwing the ball for a few hours without breaking a sweat, Yuan suddenly stops.

"What's wrong? Are you feeling tired again?" Xiao Hua asked him.

"My sister is calling for me; it is time for dinner," he said.

"You are going to leave?" Her expression instantly turned gloomy upon hearing his words, feeling reluctant to let him leave. She was afraid that he wouldn't come back once he had left.

"Don't leave Xiao Hua alone!" She hurriedly said, almost breaking into tears.

Yuan patted her head with a smile. "I will be back to play with you later, I promise."

"...You promise?"

"If I break my promise, then I shall swallow ten thousand needles!" He swore clearly in a loud voice.

"Okay... then Xiao Hua will wait for Brother Yuan here." She took a seat by the same tree and closed her eyes to rest.

"Log off!"

Yuan's vision blurred, and the warmth in his limbs gradually disappeared. Darkness surrounded his view, and he could no longer see nor feel anything.

"Brother, how was the game?" His sister's voice resounded beside him.

"It was... fun." He showed a gentle smile, but deep inside, he was reluctant to leave that bright and colorful world where his body was not useless.

"What's for dinner today?" He asked her despite already knowing the answer.

"Chicken soup!"

Yuan smiled bitterly. He has been eating nothing but soup for the last few years, after all.

"Here, let me help you up." She took off the helmet on his head before lifting his head and adjusting his body to a sitting position.

She began feeding him warm soup with a spoon soon later. "How is the temperature?"

"Perfect..."

The room became quiet with Yuan drinking soup being the only sound that could be heard.

After Yuan finished dinner that was only one large bowl of soup, she laid him back down on the bed. "I will be right back for your cleaning," she said.

Moments later, she returns to the room with a towel, a bucket of warm water, and new clothes.

"Excuse me, brother." She said before stripping him completely naked.

"...Yu Rou..."

"What is it?"

"I'm sorry..."

"..."

The room instantly turned silent.

"What are you saying now? You are being weird, brother," she chuckled, breaking the silence.

"I know, but I am — Mmm?!" His words were interrupted by a warm towel pressing down on his face.

"You don't have to worry about me, brother. When you cure your illness one day, then you can pay me back."

"...Un..." An indescribable feeling welled up in Yuan's heart.

'Will such a day ever come?' he wondered inwardly.

"Okay! You are all clean now, brother! Even your precious little thing! Hehe..." Teased Yu Rou with a sheepish laugh.

"Ah! You little! Don't play around with my body because I can't feel anything!"

"Eh? What are you talking about? I definitely did not touch anything!"

"You definitely did!"

Laughter filled the room.

"Yu Rou, thank you." Yuan suddenly said, "I will repay you one day, this I promise..."

Putting his clothes on for him, Yu Rou smiled, "I won't be humble when that time comes."

—

"Alright brother, we are done for tonight. I will be back in the morning."

"Ah, can you put the helmet back on before you leave?"

"You want to continue playing? What about sleep?"

"I don't think I can sleep tonight, and playing the game is already considered sleeping, you know?"

"What am I going to do with you if you get addicted? Only tonight, okay?"

"Un."

—

"Brother Yuan, you're really back!" Xiao Hua instantly stood up with a happy expression upon seeing him appear out of nowhere like a ghost.

"I did make a promise to you," he patted her, who was poking her head at him with clear indications.

"What do you want to do now that the stars are already out?" he then asked.

"Play games!" She answered without hesitation.

"I figured." He nodded with a smile.

Chapter 4 - Hidden Ques

Yuan continued to play with Xiao Hua throughout the night without a care in the world. Meanwhile, other Players were either trying to find the best way to strengthen themselves or were already in the process of grinding their strength.

The Players also grew addicted to their new profound strength, with the power to smash rocks with mere fists and skip meters into the distance; it gave them a sense of superiority, and it made them feel really good about themselves.

However, for someone who is crippled and blind in the real world, Yuan wouldn't mind spending all of his time just playing with Xiao Hua, who has many resemblances to his younger sister.

The world under the night sky seemed still, with the only thing moving being two shadowy figures and a ball.

"Xiao Hua, will you be fine with playing out here till so late? Won't your parents be worried if you don't return soon?" Yuan asked her after noticing that she has been out here playing with him for nearly the entire day.

"It is okay. Xiao Hua is always out here playing by herself, so they are used to it."

"..." His pity towards her increased with every passing moment he spent with her. "Xiao Hua, how about we take a rest from playing and let me tell you some more stories?"

"Stories?" Her eyes began flickering like the stars in the night sky upon hearing the magic word, and she instantly sat by the tree.

Yuan followed and sat beside her. "The stories I will be telling you today are fairy tales from my homeland."

"Fairy tales? Like mythology and legends?"

"Well... not exactly. Fairy tales are more short stories made for entertainment rather than legends and such. They are pure fiction, so it's not real."

"What's the difference?"

"...You will know when you hear it."

Yuan began telling her famous and classical fairy tales from Earth that he's heard when he was young such as a certain individual poisoning a girl who awakened due to a kiss from a prince, mermaids in the ocean, and pirates fighting in the sea.

While it has been many years since Yuan has heard of these stories, he was still able to recall them clearly and greatly entertain Xiao Hua, who was not used to this genre of stories.

"These people... are they all mortals?" She suddenly asked him.

"To my knowledge, yes."

"This is nothing like stories of mythical beasts ruling the world or immortals overturning Heaven. It is normal, yet it brings so much entertainment." She didn't know mortals could be so entertaining despite being the focus of these stories.

"Do you have any more fairy tales to tell Xiao Hua?" She asked.

"Unfortunately, that was all I could remember. But I will find some more to tell you later."

"It's a promise!"

"It's a promise." Yuan smiled.

"Okay, then it is Xiao Hua's turn to read." She opened the same book she used to teach him Heaven's Secret Art.

"That's..." Yuan wondered if she was going to teach him another skill.

"Although Brother Yuan has already learned the technique, you have not fully mastered it. However, with your powerful comprehension skills, Xiao Hua believes that Brother Yuan will master it in no time."

Thus, she began reading.

However, this time around, Yuan was only able to understand everything from the beginning only to lose comprehension later on. It felt like he was listening to a story with a plot that quickly deepens as it progresses, becoming more mysterious and profound.

—

It took Xiao Hua nearly an hour to finish reading the book that was only a dozen pages thick.

When she finished, she looked at Yuan to see the expression he was making. He was sitting still with his eyes closed, and on his face was a calm expression, looking as though he was in a trance.

'Brother Yuan is truly a genius💎💎' she mumbled to herself, 'What takes others many tries to comprehend takes you only one time. What takes others many years to learn — you learn in just a few hours.'

Her gaze stared at his face nonstop, seemingly enchanted by his expression. 'Who are you, really?'

—

«Your comprehension for Heaven's Secret Art has greatly increased»

«Heaven's Secret Art Mastery Level has been increased(1 -> 2)»

«You have learned Heaven's Second Secret Art — Heaven Splitting Sword Strike»

—

«Heaven's Second Secret Art — Heaven Splitting Sword Strike»

«Rank: Divine»

«Mastery Level: 1»

«Description: Consumes 10,000 Qi. Must wield a sword to activate. Creates a pillar of light that will destroy everything that dares to block its path.»

—

When Yuan opened his eyes again, Xiao Hua was resting her head on his lap, and the night sky had already long passed with the sun peeking in the horizon.

"It's already morning?" He wondered how long he had been in that trance state.

"Oh... You're awake, Brother Yuan." Xiao Hua rubbed her eyes and casually sat up. "Did you learn anything new during your enlightenment?"

"Enlightenment? Is that what that feeling was?"

"Un."

"I see... Right, I have reached the second stage of Heaven's Secret Art and learned Heaven Splitting Sword Strike."

Xiao Hua looked at him with her eyes slightly widened more than usual, seemingly filled with surprise.

"Good job, Brother Yuan." She gave him a thumbs up a moment later. "But your cultivation base is lacking, so you will not be able to use it right away."

"Right, it says I need 10,000 Qi for its activation. Is it the same Qi as the one I absorb when cultivating?"

She nodded to his question.

"It says I have 5,010/10,000 Qi right now. If I max it out and use the skill, won't my Qi be depleted and I will have to cultivate until I gain it back?"

"Your depleted Qi will naturally recover until it returns to its original state so you will not have to cultivate every time you use a technique. However, recovering Qi naturally takes time, and it will slow down your cultivation. That is why Cultivators do not use their Qi pointlessly." Xiao Hua explained to him as though she was an expert. "Additionally, if your Qi falls below a certain point, then your body will be in a weakened state until you recover your Qi. In extreme cases, you may lose consciousness or even the ability to Cultivate."

Yuan took his time digesting all of the information. "So if I have 100 Qi and I use a skill that requires 10 Qi, my remaining 90 Qi will naturally recover back to 100 without the need to cultivate?" He asked her just in case.

Seeing her nod, Yuan fully understood the system. "So it is just like any other game but with a slight twist that requires more management. Qi is required for skills but also for a breakthrough in cultivation; it would be unwise to use it unless necessary."

"Thank you, Xiao Hua. If not for you, I would still be clueless right now."

"Brother Yuan, gratitude is shown with action, not with words." She patted her own head, causing him to laugh.

"Right, right. Thank you very much..." He said with his hands on her head.

—

After Xiao Hua was satisfied, Yuan stood up and said, "It is about time for me to leave again, but I will be back later."

Xiao Hua didn't stop him this time and nodded. "Bye-bye, Brother Yuan. Play with Xiao Hua again when you get back, okay? Here, you can use this to call me." She handed him a necklace that she had just removed from her neck.

Yuan accepted the necklace without much thought. "Then, I will see you later." He waved at her before disappearing from the sunlight like a ghost.

After Yuan left, Xiao Hua stared at where he stood before logging off, seemingly in a daze. "Thank you, for playing with Xiao Hua..." Her body suddenly began to flicker, and her body glowed with beautiful light.

"It was fun... really, really fun..." Her body slowly broke down into tiny lights resembling fireflies before floating towards the clouds and disappearing.

«Congratulations! Player Yuan has completed the world's first Hidden Quest!»

"Brother Yuan..." That night, a sweet and childish voice echoed across the starry sky.

Chapter 5 - Death Penalty

"Good morning, brother."

"Morning."

"I have breakfast with me," she said, placing the bowl of soup on the adjustable table on the bed.

"Yu Rou, can I ask you for a favor?" Yuan asked her as he's being fed like a patient in a hospital.

"What is it?"

"I'd like to hear some fairy tales tonight." His words dumbfounded her, who wasn't expecting such a request.

"Why fairy tales?" She asked in a worrying tone, afraid the illness might have finally messed up his mind.

"I made a friend in the game, and she happens to be a young NPC. I promised her that I'd tell her more fairy tales," he explained.

"You are telling fairy tales to NPCs? Brother... what are you doing, really?" Yu Rou sighed, thinking how silly he was being.

"Don't let the fact that they are NPCs fool you into thinking that they are not worth your time. They move, think, react, and speak like real Players. You wouldn't know if they are a real Player or not unless you ask them.

"Yeah, yeah. Just don't do anything weird to her, alright?"

"W...Weird? Why would I do anything weird?" Yuan asked.

"Haven't you heard? There have been plenty of perverts getting killed for touching NPCs inappropriately. The penalty for death is extremely harsh in this game from what I heard."

"Perverts touching NPCs? You can do that in this game?" Yuan lifted his eyebrows in surprise. What a profound game!

"Ah! You're thinking about doing something perverted, aren't you!? Don't even think about it, brother! I prohibit you from doing that as your sister!"

"That only works if you are the older one, no?" He smiled.

"Then... then I will stop taking care of you! Hmph!"

"Aiii... Do you think your brother is some kind of pervert that likes to touch NPCs? Unlike some people, I have morals, you know." He sighed, and continued to speak, "Anyway, what is this death penalty, and what happens if you die?" He was more interested in that than the perverts in the game.

"According to those who have died, some became unable to cultivate after death while some have even lost their cultivation base entirely, requiring them to restart from scratch."

Yuan pondered. "So you basically have to start from the beginning... That is indeed very harsh for a game."

"Additionally, some people have already tried to buy new consoles to start fresh but guess what? They still appear in the game with the same character!"

"So we are limited to one character no matter what?" Yuan cannot comprehend the game creators' motive for creating such a system; it's almost as if they want humans to live in another world with life as realistic as possible.

"Ah, brother, it's time for me to go to school. I will pick up some fairy tales on the way home," she said before leaving.

"Thank you."

"She's not here..." Yuan looked around for a small figure, but Xiao Hua was nowhere to be found. "I guess she went home."

He decided to sit down and cultivate to wait for her. Seconds turned into minutes, and minutes turned into hours. Until night came, Yuan sat there like a stone statue, cultivating and unaware that time had passed by so quickly.

10,000/10,000

«You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough»

«You have reached Second Level Spirit Apprentice»

«All stats +150»

10,005/20,000

20,000/20,000

«You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough»

«You have reached Third Level Spirit Apprentice»

«All stats +200»

20,005/40,000

40,000/40,000

«You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough»

«You have reached Fourth Level Spirit Apprentice»

«All stats +250»

80,000/80,000

«You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough»

«You have reached Fifth Level Spirit Apprentice»

«All stats +300»

148,550/160,000

Yuan did not stop cultivating until it was time for him to eat dinner. "We couldn't play today but that's fine. At least I will have stories ready for the next time we meet." He stared at the night sky for a moment before logging off.

—

After feeding Yuan and getting him cleaned, Yu Rou began reading fairy tales to him like a mother would tell stories to her child before bedtime, but her voice was still too immature to sound like a real mother.

"How was my narration?" she asked him in a cheeky tone.

"It sucked..."

"What—Fine! You can read it yourself next time!"

"Ah! I'm sorry, Yu Rou. I was only joking." Yuan hurriedly corrected himself, "Your voice was so heavenly that I thought you were a real fairy!"

Yu Rou blushed. "It was embarrassing to read these childish stories out loud, you know?" she said later, "I will remember this debt you owe me!"

"Yes yes, I will even give you my life, so find me a few more fairy tales, okay?"

"..."

"Yu Rou?" He called out to her after receiving no answer.

"Brother, please don't say things like that ever again," said Yu Rou with a serious expression on her face, her voice somewhat sorrowful.

Yuan quickly realized that he had screwed up. "I'm sorry..." he apologized right away.

"As long as you understand..." Yu Rou left his side to close the light, "Brother, it is getting late, you should go to sleep now."

"Un. Goodnight."

"Goodnight, brother."

—

Inside her room, Yu Rou surfed the internet on her phone for some time before sleeping like always.

"This player Yuan is very mysterious and baffling. In just two days since the game's launch, he was able to become the first Player to obtain a Divine-rank skill and finish a Hidden Quest. Is he even human?"

Despite not being able to play the game due to school and Yuan, she would still keep up with the newest information about the game so when the time comes for her to play, she wouldn't feel too lost. "Meanwhile, my brother is fooling around with a young NPC..." she smiled bitterly at that thought.

"Wow, his bounty has increased to five million already!" Her eyes widened at the effort and money others were willing to put out just to find this one player.

"So much fame... how envious..." she turned the phone off and closed her eyes. "Brother too... used to be flickering with lights under the spotlight..." she sighed before slowly falling asleep.

Chapter 6 - Servants

"How is the search going? Have you found any information on this player Yuan yet?" A handsome young man sat on his bed with Cultivation Online's console—the helmet— still on his head, his gaze at the middle-aged man standing by the door.

"Sorry, young master, but this player seems resolute in keeping his identity a secret. Not even our offer was able to lure him out," said the middle-aged man in a tired tone. He has gone without sleep for the past two days just to look for information on Yuan, but alas, the results came back in a box of disappointment filled with a whole lot of nothing.

"Not taking the bait? Then all we have to do is increase the temptation. Go and adjust the reward to twenty million. Unless this player is already super wealthy, then he will surely bite the bait sooner or later," said the young man casually, as though twenty million means nothing in his eyes.

"Understood." The middle-aged man then left the young man alone.

"I will have my hands on this player no matter the price. This individual is either Lady Luck's child or has connections to the game creators, allowing him to obtain things in the game that normal people will never have a chance to obtain. If I get him to join my faction, then my family's position within the ranks will surely rise!"

Similar scenes played out throughout the world with many high-standing figures doing whatever they can in their power to learn more about this player Yuan who is already light-years ahead of everyone else in the game, unaware that Yuan still has no idea how much of a stir he has created in the real world just because of a few system announcements. While Cultivation

Online is just a mere game in Yuan's eyes, that was not the case for others, who have their own ulterior motives.

After eating breakfast, Yuan went into the game, but alas, the small figure of Xiao Hua's was still nowhere to be found.

"Did she get in trouble with her family for staying out so late?" He thought of that possibility. "Maybe she was lying about her family not worrying so we could play for a bit longer..."

Yuan sighed, missing the cheerful little girl. Without her, what else is there to do in this world? Strength, wealth, fame — Yuan was not interested in any of these. All he wanted to do was have fun and use his body normally, something he cannot achieve in the real world.

He pulled out the necklace she gave him before she left. Shaking his head, he sighed. "I shouldn't be so impatient. I will wait for her just like she had waited for my return."

Thus, he sat down to cultivate again. While it was boring at first, as he slowly grew used to cultivating, he began feeling pleasure, like getting a massage during a nap.

Time passed quickly, and the night sky appears once again.

160,000/160,000

«You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough»

«You have reached Sixth Level Spirit Apprentice»

«All stats +350»

320,000/320,000

«You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough»

«You have reached Seventh Level Spirit Apprentice»

«You have learned Enhanced Senses»

«All stats +400»

—

«Enhanced Sense»

«Rank: N/A»

«Description: Permanently enhances the functions of all available senses. Requires no activation.»

—

320,295/640,000

"It is taking longer and longer to advance to the next level, and the requirement needed is doubling with every level. Just how many more levels is there?" Yuan pondered, but knowing he's still an apprentice makes him worry about the later stages. "It will take a month of straight cultivating to advance one level in the later stages at this rate! This cultivation thing is such a chore..."

Just as Yuan was about to log off for tonight, an announcement appears in the sky, attracting countless gazes from below.

«Congratulations! Player White Lotus has become the world's first player to have obtained a Servant!»

While Yuan wondered what type of Servant this White Lotus had obtained, everybody else was surprised to see 'Player White Lotus' instead of 'Player Yuan' who was thought to have another shock for the world. But of course, many players were also relieved to know that Yuan would no longer be the only 'Ancestor' in the world.

'Ancestor' is a title created by the community that refers to those who have appeared in the system as a 'world's first' after Yuan's first announcement.

"Servants, huh." Yuan suddenly began having desires of obtaining a Servant. But how does one obtain a Servant?

After logging off the game, Yu Rou was already beside him with dinner in her hands.

"Yu Rou, how do you obtain Servants in this game?" He decided to ask her.

"Servants? Did someone obtain a Servant already?" She asked with curiosity. "Also, I don't know anything about obtaining Servants."

"It was someone named White Lotus."

"White Lotus!" Yu Rou immediately recognized that name. "She is one of the top players at the moment who has a cultivation base at Fifth Level Spirit Apprentice! Furthermore, she is actually a rich young lady in real life, too."

"Fifth Level Spirit Apprentice is considered the top?" Yuan, who is already a Seventh Level Spirit Apprentice, was surprised to hear that someone who is two whole levels behind him is at the top.

'Are they really top players? I barely cultivated and I'm already two levels above one of the top rankers!' He wondered.

"Yu Rou, who has the highest cultivation in the game as of this moment?"

"I believe it is someone known as Lightning Emperor, who is a Sixth Level Spirit Apprentice."

"Whoa, what an edgy name..."

"That's what you're concerned about?" Yu Rou chuckled. "Say, what's your cultivation now? Since you spent most of your time fooling around, it

should be pretty low, right? Let me take a guess... you are a Second Level Spirit Apprentice."

Yuan grinned, "Wrong!"

"First Level Spirit Apprentice?"

"Wrong again."

"What... Don't tell me... you have yet to cultivate?!"

"Yu Rou, since when have I become so pitiful and weak in your eyes? Your brother is disappointed..." Yuan said in a sorrowful voice. "Aiii, nevermind, I am just a nobody in the game, anyway. And like you have said, I have been fooling around, so hurry up and play with me so we can do things together."

"This week is impossible since I still have school, but next week for sure when summer break begins."

"School, huh. I am envious." Yuan smiled bitterly.

"Going to school is nothing to be envious about, brother. It is boring and tiring," sighed Yu Rou.

"But I still envy you and every student out there..." He sighed inwardly.

After talking for a few more minutes, Yu Rou went back to her room to sleep, and Yuan himself also went to sleep.

"If she doesn't appear by tomorrow, I should use that necklace..." He told himself before falling asleep.

Chapter 7 - Heaven Splitting Sword Strike

"Xiao Hua, where are you? Your favorite brother is here to play with you!" Yuan shouted loudly in the forest the moment he logged into the game.

"Aiii... What am I doing?" He sat down afterward, his hand reaching for the necklace around his neck.

Despite it seemingly made out of steel with a piece of jade attached, the necklace was as light as a feather, nearly weightless.

«Xiao Hua's Necklace»

«Grade: ???»

«Description: Obtained from Xiao Hua.»

"Even though she said to use this to call her... how do I use it?" He played around with the necklace as he pondered.

He tried poking it, caressing it, commanding it to open, even licking it, but alas, the necklace remained unchanged. After many minutes and many failures later, Yuan decided to stop trying to activate the necklace.

"Oh, Xiao Hua. How can you give me something so complicated without explaining its functions?" He sighed loudly.

Suddenly, as though the heavens heard his sigh, the earth trembled.

—

The sound of metal clashing resounded, followed by loud cursing.

"Eat my Coiling Sword Strike, you bastard!"

"Courting death!"

Boom! A loud explosion appeared in the distance, startling Yuan. What just happened? Why did the earth tremble the way it did just now? Did someone drop a bomb?

Clang! The sound of metal clashing resounded again, and a gust of wind suddenly swept the place, nearly lifting Yuan into the air.

"Devil Meng Li! If I don't kill you today, then I am not Zhan Xuegang!"

"Ahahaha! A mere half-step Spirit Grandmaster like you think you can kill me? Today will be the day you will realize your foolish existence — in hell!"

Clang! Clang! Clang!

Visible ripples filled with profound power swiftly swept the sky after every clash, sending chills down Yuan's spine every time it swept past him.

"It is actually two people fighting against each other that is causing this phenomenon?!" Yuan was shocked, to say the least. "To fight in someone else's garden, how disrespectful!"

Soon, two figures could be seen fighting each other in the air from where Yuan stood. One with long red hair and one with long black hair. They were flying back and forth, throwing powerful sword strikes at each other that would create ripples upon being blocked by the other person.

"They are flying, just like that old man!" Yuan recalled Elder Song, the old man who gave him and thousands of other players a brief explanation about this world while standing on a sword in the air.

The fight in the air lasted for many minutes without either one gaining an advantage over the other; they seemed to be equally matched.

However, as they were getting closer and closer to where Yuan stood, the destructive ripples created by their sword clashes also became painful to bear for him.

Despite not being apart of the fight, Yuan could feel a dominating pressure making it difficult for him to breathe, and his body felt as though it was carrying a large rock.

"Die for me! Seven Earthly Sword Strikes!"

"Ahahaha! Too weak! Way too weak! Bloody Sword Strike!"

A ripple far superior to the previous swept through the place until it could no longer be seen on the horizon.

Cough! Yuan could no longer resist the pressure and coughed up a mouthful of blood. "Damn! This is really uncomfortable!" He wiped the blood from his mouth with his hand.

"I can even taste the iron-like taste of blood..." Yuan was completely immersed at this moment. The pain in his body and the realistic features of this game temporarily made him forget that this was just a game.

"If they get any closer, I will definitely die from collateral damage!" He began running away from the two, but the clashes between them were also getting stronger.

"Nine Earthly Sword Strikes!"

"Devil's Blood!"

Boom! Trees fell and the clouds scattered from the impact, and Yuan was sent flying towards a tree, losing consciousness a moment later.

—

"Hahahaha! Zhan Xuegang, what's wrong? Didn't you say that you will kill me today?" One of the figures began laughing while pointing at the other

person who was missing an arm. "The Prime Disciple of the Profound Sword Sect is only so-so—just like that junior sister of yours... Hahahaha!"

"I will... I WILL KILL YOU!" Zhan Xuegang roared, his eyes turned red, and his cultivation base suddenly increased dramatically.

"What!?" The eyes of Devil Ming Li widened from shock. "You... you had a breakthrough in the middle of our fight?!"

"I will avenge Junior apprentice-sister Xia today by killing you even if I have to lose all four of my limbs and become a cripple!" His eyes and nose began bleeding, and veins appeared all over his body.

"Was she your lover by any chance? Then let me tell you something important before you die... her body was amazing! It is truly a pity that she had killed herself so quickly or else I would have surely enjoyed her body even more! Hahahaha!"

"MENG LI, GO TO HELLLLLLL!!!!" The blue sword in Zhan Xuegang's grasp glowed a dark blue light, and killing intent soared beyond the clouds.

"SPIRIT BLADE!"

"Trying to bring me down with you? Just because you are now a Spirit Grandmaster like me does not mean we are on equal standing, you fool!" Meng Li's red hair glowed a crimson color along with his eyes, looking like a real devil from hell.

"Hell's Fire!"

Suddenly, before the two of them could release their techniques, a little girl in red robes appeared in-between them like a ghost, and in her grasp was a necklace covered in fresh blood.

"For disturbing the peace of our place, your cultivation base shall be crippled as a punishment." The little girl waved her sleeves, and Meng Li and Zhan Xuegang felt their entire cultivation base collapse an instant later.

Without any cultivation to support them, the two were no longer able to control their attacks or fly, and they fell straight to the ground, breaking many bones upon hitting the earth.

"Who are you?!" Meng Li cried out loud as he laid on the ground, experiencing major pain across his body. To cripple him, a Spirit Grandmaster, with a mere wave of her sleeves, her background must be shocking.

As for Zhan Xuegang, he could only stare at the little girl in the air with wide eyes. He was too shocked to think.

"What did we do to offend you?! Answer me!" Meng Li shouted again after receiving no answer from her.

However, the little girl ignored him, descended from the sky to a nearby tree, and walked to where Yuan's unconscious body laid.

"That's the trash who was watching us fight..." Meng Li was aware of Yuan's presence and that he had been watching them, but because he was too weak to affect them, Meng Li treated Yuan like an ant and ignored him. The same goes for Zhan Xuegang.

The little girl kneeled to wipe the blood off Yuan's lips, her hands trembling slightly. "For injuring him... you shall be punished with death..."

After wiping the blood from Yuan's lips, the little girl stood and turned to face the two figures lying on the floor, her expression grim and filled with killing intent.

"Heaven Splitting Sword Strike..." The world suddenly trembled, and the heaven dimmed, almost turning into night. And a sword made from a golden light appeared in the grasp of the little girl.

"Heaven Splitting Sword Strike?! Impossible! What are you doing here in the Lower Heavens?!" Zhan Xuegang recognized the technique being witnessed, and his heart nearly stopped from shock.

The little girl ignored his question and suddenly slashed the sword downwards, and the heavens seemed to have split into two at that moment.

BOOM! A massive earthquake shook the entire Eastern Continent, shocking many experts within the continent, even alerting many ancient experts around the world.

—

Yuan slowly opened his eyes, and the first thing that he noticed was the obviously large earth fissure in front of him with an end that he cannot physically see, looking as though it separated the earth in half.

"What—Did those two cause this?! This is ridiculous!" Yuan's back was soaked in cold sweat upon seeing the earth fissure that seemed endless. He couldn't imagine the power that was required to cause this much destruction. This earth fissure was more than enough to change the geography of this world!

Suddenly, Yuan's heart jumped. He slowly turned his head, and it was this moment he realized that he had been sleeping on the soft lap of this little girl.

"Xiao Hua!" He was pleasantly surprised to see her sitting beside him, even allowing him to sleep on her lap. "Are you hurt anywhere?"

Yuan felt relieved upon seeing no injuries on her.

Xiao Hua suddenly pulled his head back down to her lap. "Master, you shouldn't move too much. You are injured."

"Eh?" Yuan became dumbfounded. "What did you just call me? Master? What kind of game are we playing this time?"

"This is not a game. Xiao Hua has accepted Brother Yuan as her Master." She showed him the necklace covered in blood with a serious expression.

"That's the necklace you gave me—Oh... so that's what you meant by using that to call you... to summon you as a Servant?" He facepalmed upon

realizing the real meaning behind her words, making a loud slapping sound.
"Xiao Hua... you... Aiya!" He sighed loudly.

"Do you not accept Xiao Hua?" Her expression saddened. "Is Xiao Hua a bad girl?"

"That's not it. I really like you, but... to keep you as a Servant is too much... since it will cause many unnecessary misunderstandings..."

"Misunderstands? Xiao Hua does not mind..."

'But I do!' Yuan replied inside his head.

After a moment of silence, Yuan finally said to her, "Brother Yuan."

"Huh?" Xiao Hua looked at him with a puzzled expression on her face.

"As long as you call me Brother Yuan like normally, then there will be no misunderstandings." He explained to her.

"Then..." Her eyes began sparkling. "Brother Yuan!"

She suddenly hugged him, hiding the bashful smile on her face.

«You have accepted Xiao Hua as your Servant!»

Name: Xiao Hua

Servant Grade: Divine

Master: Yuan

Cultivation: Third Level Spirit King

Legacy: Supreme Heaven's Legacy

Bloodline: Divine Bloodline

Physique: Purple Mist Physique

«Heaven's Secret Art»

«Rank: Divine»

«Mastery Level: 4»

«Heaven's First Secret Art — Consuming Heaven Technique»

«Rank: Divine»

«Mastery Level: 5»

«Heaven's Second Secret Art — Heaven Splitting Sword Strike»

«Rank: Divine»

«Mastery Level: 4»

«Heaven's Third Secret Art — Heavenly Domain»

«Rank: Divine»

«Mastery Level: 2»

«Heaven's Fourth Secret Art — Heaven Sealing Technique»

«Rank: Divine»

«Mastery Level: 1»

«Fly»

«Rank: Earth»

«Superior Senses»

«Rank: Heaven»

«Qi Manifestation»

«Rank: Earth»

«Purple Mist»

«Rank: Divine»

«Congratulations! Player Yuan has obtained the world's first Divine grade Servant!»

When the announcement appeared above the sky, countless cries of shock resounded around the world, and rumors of Player Yuan being a cheater quickly began spreading like wildfire on this day.

Chapter 8 - An Overwhelming Advantage

"What the hell! This player Yuan is clearly already at endgame while the rest of us are still picking herbs just to earn barely enough money for a common weapon!"

"The game hasn't even been out for a week and he is already obtaining things that will probably take months, even years of grinding!"

"Can he even be considered a player at this point anymore? He is ahead of the entire player-base—and not by a small margin!"

"At this rate, couldn't he potentially rule over everybody at some point?"

"This asshole must be cheating! There is no way he can obtain all these things so quickly. Even the current best players are nowhere near him, and I refuse to believe that some no-name can possibly be so far ahead of everyone else without cheating!"

"That's right! He's clearly cheating! Where are the admins? What about the game creators? He needs to be punished!"

"He either has balls that are hard as steel or he's completely nuts. To cheat so openly, does he think it wouldn't raise even a little bit of suspicion?"

Rumors of Yuan cheating in the game began spreading like wildfire across the internet.

Cheaters nowadays, especially in popular games, are punished more severely than older times where cheating would only be frowned upon but nobody really tries anything major to stop them.

Furthermore, if you are caught cheating, then there is a high possibility of receiving a fine that is more expensive than ten years of rent for housing, and there are even many cases of cheaters being jailed for up to four years.

With so many risks involved, only those who are rich and really don't care would be willing to cheat.

However, even these types of people wouldn't cheat so openly. So in Yuan's case, people could only assume that he was completely nuts to be so obvious in the current most popular game in the world!

—

"Cheating, huh. What do you think, White Lotus? Do you also believe this Yuan to be a cheater?" A handsome young man in purple robes kicked the decapitated wolf head by his feet to the side. In his grasp was a steel sword with a black handle, and blue lightning snakes would coil around the blade every so often that was dripping with fresh blood.

Beside him stood two other people, both beautiful ladies.

The beautiful young lady with elegant features by his side silently stared at the announcement in the sky. "Whether he is cheating or not does not concern me," she said a moment later, her gaze switching from the announcement to the large black cat beside her. "But I am interested in what a Divine-rank Servant would look like..."

Her Two-tailed Black Cat is a normal monster without a grade, but it has great agility and powerful attacks. If compared to Cultivators, then its power would be equivalent to a Fourth Level Spirit Apprentice.

"This Divine-grade Servant... with this, his influence within and outside the game is massive and can no longer be ignored, and his actions could very well greatly impact the world..."

"What's this? Is the Lightning Emperor, ranked third in the Legacy Ranking, feeling pressure from a no-name?" The other beautiful lady laughed charmingly.

"Do you feel nothing regarding our situation, Fiery Queen?" Lightning Emperor looked at her with a serious expression. "This is not a joking matter. Forget about me, the entire Legacy Ranking may be thrown into disorder because of this Yuan."

"I'd be lying if I say I am not interested in this Player, but the entire Legacy Ranking? That's an exaggeration. He's is probably just another cheater."

"What if he turns out to be the real deal, someone with extreme luck and skills? What will you do then?"

The cheerful expression on Fiery Queen's face turned serious after his question. "Then I will obviously do what I have to and recruit him."

"Hah! Do you think you are the only one with that thought? Forget about the Feng Family who is currently ranked first, every family within the Legacy Ranking is actively looking for him even as we speak!"

"Che. I know that already. But it doesn't matter how many are looking for him. As long I find him first, then he will be mine!"

Lightning Emperor only snorted at her words. "Talking to you is a waste of breath."

—

"We're here... the Skeleton Graveyard." Lightning Emperor readied his sword, his awareness alert.

In front of the current three top players was a large graveyard with many skeletons walking around awkwardly, like wooden puppets with stiff movements.

"Let's quickly finish this. I am feeling sick just from your presence," said Fiery Queen.

"You willingly followed us..."

"Only because we happen to have accepted the same quest."

"Che. Let's go. They have already noticed us."

Fiery Queen retrieved her weapon, which was a long whip. White Lotus followed, holding a normal-looking sword in front of her.

Despite being top players, neither of them had any chance to obtain weapons with a grade, so they can only put up with these normal weapons with no grade.

"Lightning Element." Lightning Emperor caressed his sword, causing the lightning snakes to return, coiling around the blade as though it was dancing.

"Body Enhancement—Speed." Fiery Queen's supple body glowed blue, and her body could no longer feel any weight, feeling as though she has become as light as a feather.

"Xu Hei." White Lotus said softly, and the black cat stood in front of her.

"Let's go!" Lightning Emperor kicked his feet, flying towards the skeletons at a quick speed.

"Don't order me around!" Fiery Queen also charged forward, followed by White Lotus and her Servant.

—

"Xiao Hua... you..." Yuan was shocked upon seeing her character status. Although he doesn't understand what they meant, they were obviously not ordinary.

"To have a companion this powerful so early on in the game... Isn't this technically cheating?" Yuan was aware of the advantage he currently has over all the other players, but because he isn't playing for competitive reasons, he doesn't on planning to use this advantage.

"Say, Xiao Hua. Compared to a Spirit Apprentice cultivator, how much stronger are you as a Spirit King?" He asked her so he could better comprehend the differences between them.

"..." Xiao Hua looked at him weirdly for a moment before saying, "one thousand... ten thousand...? Brother Yuan, they cannot be compared because the difference is too vast."

"The difference is too vast? How so?"

"Hmmm... That mountain over there... Xiao Hua can make it disappear with one attack." She pointed at the large mountain at the horizon and said casually.

"Disappear with one attack?" Yuan's eyes popped when he heard her confident words. If what she said was true, wouldn't that make her a walking bomb with destructive power equivalent to a nuke? One that can be used multiple times? How could she possibly be a mere Servant? Wouldn't her existence be considered a bit unbalanced for a game? Or are all cultivators this powerful once they reach a certain stage?

Yuan couldn't help but wonder what the game creators were thinking when they thought that giving such a small girl like her so much power would be a great idea.

"Xiao Hua, do not use your powers recklessly, okay? I don't want to see you accidentally destroy a city or a piece of land—" He suddenly turned to look at the earth fissure, his eyes wide open.

"X...Xiao Hua... did you do this?" He asked her after having a feeling that it wasn't the two cultivators who had created this mess.

"Un." She nodded calmly, seemingly thinking nothing much of it.

"Aiii!" Yuan sighed loudly. "What if you had accidentally hit somebody with that? Xiao Hua, listen up. Do not use your power unless I give you permission, okay?"

"Un." She accepted his request quite easily.

"Good." Yuan looked at the earth fissure one more time before turning away with a bitter smile on his face. "Let's go, Xiao Hua. It'd be bad if someone

were to see us here right now..."

Thus, the two began walking further from the crime scene.

—

"Xiao Hua, what will you do now that you have become my Servant?" Yuan asked her, still unsure of what the purpose of Servants is in this game.

"Xiao Hua will follow Brother Yuan wherever he goes," she answered quickly. "And she will lead you to the next realm."

"Huh? Lead me to the next realm?"

"Un."

"Well... nevermind that for now. What about your family? What will they say if you decide to leave home to follow me?"

"Brother Yuan is Xiao Hua's family now, so there are no problems." She looked at him with flickering eyes.

"I don't think that logic would work..." He shook his head, unsure of what to do with her.

Taking a child who he met only a few days ago away from her family would cause countless problems if this was the real world, but Yuan recalled that he was in a game and she is only an NPC, so there shouldn't be any problems.

"Alright, do as you wish, Xiao Hua." He finally said with a forfeiting smile.

Chapter 9 - Jade Frog

«Congratulations! Player Lightning Emperor, Player White Lotus, and Player Fiery Queen has become the first players to have cleared Skeleton Graveyard!»

The sudden announcement shocked many players, but it was not because they were the first to clear this dungeon but because three different families from the Legacy Ranking were grouped together! In other words, they were cooperating, something that is rarely seen by the public, if ever.

"Holy shit! Three of the top 10 families within the Legacy are actually cooperating to clear a dungeon together!"

"Perhaps they have decided to make an alliance to bring down this Player Yuan?"

"That is a possibility..."

Many players gossiped about the new announcement online, some even making conspiracies. The Legacy Ranking is a system in the real world — or a real-world ranking so to speak, where professional players fight each other competitively to obtain a spot within the Legacy Ranking.

There can only be 100 players in the Legacy Ranking, ranked one to one hundred. Being a part of the Legacy Ranking brings countless profits and almost no downfalls. Wealth, fame, authority, power — one can obtain all that just by being in the Legacy Ranking. Additionally, once a player becomes a part of the Legacy Ranking, regardless of their rank, their family will also become a Legacy Family, allowing them to recruit talented players to help them remain or climb the ranks within the Legacy Ranking, almost like a guild or clan in games.

Countless players, young and old, fight in worldwide tournaments just to obtain the qualifications to challenge someone who is within the Legacy Ranking to steal their spot. Furthermore, only one game would be chosen every decade as the focus. Because of this, the rankings would usually have major changes every decade, except for those at the very top of the ranking.

The game the Legacy Ranking had chosen to be the main focus for this decade was obviously Cultivation Online, the hottest VRMMORPG in the world to date.

Moments after the announcement, another one appears above the clouds.

«Congratulations! Player Xiong Lu has obtained the world's first Spirit grade equipment!»

"He's finally appeared, huh." Lightning Emperor narrowed his gaze at the name on the announcement.

Xiong Lu of the Heaven's Divinity, standing at the top of the Legacy Ranking as the number one Player in this world. He is a major figure even in the real world, owning one of the biggest gaming companies out there.

"Even an unsurpassable monster like him could only obtain the lowest grade equipment in this game after so many hours... yet this Yuan..." Fiery Queen sighed loudly.

"Xiao Hua, what are the grades for equipment?" Yuan asked her after the announcement disappeared.

"Spirit, Earth, Heaven, Divine, each broken into four tiers of quality: Low, Medium, High, and Peak. There are other grades higher than Divine, but there is no need to worry about that since you can only find them in the higher realms."

"Realm... you also mentioned that before. What did you mean by bringing me to the next realm?"

"Brother Yuan is currently in the lowest realm — the Lower Heaven. Xiao Hua's job is to help Brother Yuan reach the highest realm — the Supreme Heaven."

"Your job?" He questioned. Why and who would give her such a job?

"Xiao Hua accepted the Supreme Heaven's Legacy, so it became her job to find a successor."

"...What a deep game." Yuan looked at the sky, "How do we get to the next realm?" he asked.

"Brother Yuan is too weak right now and should only worry about getting stronger. After that, we can challenge the Realm Guardian for access to the next realm."

"So it's that kind of game, huh." Yuan became more understanding of the goal of this game.

"Is there a reward for getting there? The Supreme Heaven," he asked out of curiosity, not expecting anything too much.

"Everything," she answered after a moment of silence, "The winner shall obtain everything this world has to offer... so... they become this world's God."

"Eh?" Yuan totally did not expect such a generous reward. "Allowing Players to become God? So the game creators are essentially giving admin powers to those who reach that point? How generous of them."

'But I have no use for such power, so I will enjoy my life to the fullest and leave it to others to fight for that reward.' Yuan thought to himself. He was content with just having the ability to use his eyes and limbs as he wishes.

—

After walking for some time, Yuan finally realized that they were walking aimlessly without a destination. "Xiao Hua, where should we go now? Or rather, what should we do?" he asked her, who seemed to be the one leading this journey.

Xiao Hua looked at him with a nonchalant expression and said, "Help Brother Yuan get stronger."

"And how will we do that?" Although he doesn't really desire strength, it wasn't something he would refuse either.

"That..." Xiao Hua suddenly pointed to the distance where there was an open field, and in this middle of this open field was a large figure at least 5 meters tall.

"That's... a frog?" Yuan quickly blinked a few times nonstop when he saw the massive frog with jade-like skin sitting in the middle with its eyes closed, seemingly sleeping.

"That is a Jade Frog; it has power equivalent to a Ninth Level Spirit Apprentice cultivator."

"Ninth Level Spirit Apprentice?! I am only a Seventh Level Spirit Apprentice! Are you telling me to go kill myself?!" Yuan nearly cried upon hearing her words.

"Although the Jade Frog is two levels above Brother Yuan's cultivation base, it shouldn't matter because Brother Yuan has cultivated the Heaven Consuming Technique, allowing him to be stronger than most Cultivators at the same level."

"Is that really how it works?"

"Un."

"But I also don't know how to fight — Ah... it noticed us." Yuan suddenly pointed at the Jade Frog, its head turned towards their direction with killing intent radiating from its gaze.

Whoosh! The Jade Frog suddenly leaped and appeared dozens of meters into the sky, almost as though it was trying to touch the clouds.

"Watch out!" Yuan instinctively grabbed Xiao Hua by her waist with one hand and jumped back to avoid the shadow. Seconds later, the Jade Frog lands at where they originally stood, creating a dent in the ground.

"That was close..." Yuan wiped the invisible sweat from his forehead when he saw the hole on the ground. They could've been meat paste if he didn't dodge that.

"Brother Yuan, good luck." She gave him a thumbs up and casually walked to the side to watch, dumbfounding Yuan.

Thinking that she was just an ant, the Jade Frog ignored her and kept its gaze on Yuan.

"You... How am I supposed to fight this monster without any weapons?!" he cried out loud.

"Then Brother Yuan can use this..." Xiao Hua retrieved a small pouch from her robes, pulling out a steel sword from inside.

However, when she pulled out the sword, it also alerted the Jade Frog, causing it to leap towards her. In the Jade Frog's eyes, Xiao Hua, who has a weapon, was more of a threat than Yuan who was empty-handed, so it ignored Yuan and went for her instead.

"Xiao Hua! Watch out!" He shouted to warn her, but Xiao Hua only watched it fall on her with a calm expression.

Boom! The ground slightly shook when the Jade Frog landed on Xiao Hua's small frame.

Yuan's eyes widened, and his jaw dropped from shock. In his mind, Xiao Hua has most likely turned into a pancake after being squashed by the Jade Frog's massive body and weight.

Suddenly, purple mists began seeping out from beneath the Jade Frog, almost like it had farted, and Yuan returned to his senses.

The purple mist distanced itself from the Jade Frog and gathered beside Yuan, before forming into the figure of a small girl.

"Xiao Hua!" Yuan was baffled by what he'd just witnessed. What just happened?

"What's wrong, Brother Yuan?" she asked him in a normal voice as though she did not just get flattened by the Jade Frog.

"You... what happened just now?"

"Xiao Hua's Purple Mist Physique?"

"Yes... but I am also talking about why you just stood there to take its attack! You nearly gave me a heart attack!"

"But Brother Yuan said Xiao Hua cannot use her power until Xiao Hua has permission, and Xiao Hua did not have permission..."

Yuan looked at her with wide eyes, his expression perplexed. "Are you an idiot?!" he suddenly yelled at her.

Startled, Xiao Hua shrunk her head like a scared turtle.

"Even if you didn't want to use your powers, you could've just dodged! There was no reason for you to stand there and take the hit!" Yuan was upset, but mostly at himself for telling her to do something without thinking about it.

Xiao Hua is just an NPC, someone programmed to act and do things a certain way, so if Yuan told her to sit, then she will sit without questioning him, her 'master'. But Yuan didn't take into consideration that she was an NPC, who is also his Servant, and treated her as a real human, hence why he believed that she would have some logic in her when he told her to not use her power recklessly.

"Sorry..." Xiao Hua apologized.

"Aiii!" Yuan facepalmed when he saw her sad face. "I should be the one apologizing, Xiao Hua... I had told you to do something without thinking... I'm sorry."

"?"

"When I told you to not use your powers, I didn't mean to completely seal off your power and be a punching bag... If you are in danger or feel like you need to use your powers, then just use it."

"What about Brother Yuan's permission?"

"Forget I had ever said that and use it according to your judgment. What I am trying to say is there's no need to crack an egg by smashing it with a large rock, and think about your surroundings and the environment before you decide to use it."

"Xiao Hua understands." She nodded.

"Good. Now, give me that sword. I have a debt to settle with this damn frog."

The moment Yuan grabbed the steel sword by the handle, information about the sword appeared in his head.

«Spirit Sword»

«Grade: Spirit»

«Quality: Peak»

«Physical Strength Required: 900»

«Mental Strength Required: 1,500»

«Sharpness: 1,000»

«Description: Cuts metal like butter.»

"Good sword!" Yuan instantly took a liking to it after swinging it a few times in the air.

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Chapter 10 - A Natural Prodigy

The Jade Frog remained unmoving, its gaze seemingly filled with confusion as it stared at Xiao Hua, who didn't even bother to return its gaze, as though it was nothing in her eyes. How did this insignificant-looking little girl escape unscathed after being crushed by its massive weight, it wondered.

Yuan walked forward in a calm manner, his gaze deeply focused on the Jade Frog. Although he has never been in a fight before, he felt oddly calm at this moment, as though it was only natural.

"I have never been in a fight before, let alone use a sword. I have spent the majority of my life in a bed, silently rotting away. However, as powerless I may be outside of this world, I can use my limbs and eyes to the fullest in this world! As long as I am here, I feel as though I can achieve anything, even defeating this giant frog!" Yuan suddenly dashed towards the Jade Frog, alerting it. His speed was faster than even the fastest man on earth, and he arrived in front of Jade Frog in the blink of an eye.

"Witness! Remember! Learn! Execute!" The fight between the two cultivators flashed inside his head, and his hands moved accordingly.

Slash! The sword in his grasp had easily sliced the skin of the Jade Frog, causing blood to gush out from its stomach. The Jade Frog screamed from the pain, and it jumped back to avoid him.

Xiao Hua's eyes widened when she witnessed the movements of Yuan's sword. "Although it was stiff and seemed like the swing of an amateur... it was clearly a sword technique."

Yuan did not chase after the Jade Frog and only looked at the sword in his grasp, and on his face was dissatisfaction. "Che. I moved exactly as that guy

did, but something about it did not feel right..."

"Brother Yuan... you..." Xiao Hua could only be shocked. What she just witnessed was the technique of one of the two cultivators she had killed. Did he learn it just from watching them fight for a brief moment?

For someone to learn and execute a technique only after watching it once and only for a few moments, Yuan could only be described as a prodigy.

"I executed the movements perfectly and it had hit the target, but there was something missing..." Yuan pondered. "Perhaps... Qi?"

As though he had received enlightenment, Yuan smiled, and his gaze returned to the Jade Frog. "This time, I will slay you!" he exclaimed with confidence, his sword pointing at the trembling Jade Frog.

The Jade Frog was confused. The human looked incredibly weak and vulnerable just moments ago, yet the moment he grabbed the sword, everything about him changed. His weak aura became sharp like the sword, and his gaze showed dominance, even a hint of arrogance. What had happened to him that caused this change?

Even Xiao Hua was also a bit baffled by his change. It was as if he had gone from a mortal who knew nothing about the world to a profound swordmaster! Even the aura he emitted has changed entirely!

Yuan dashed towards the Jade Frog while it was dazed, and his hands maneuvered the sword in his hands with the same movements but with more precision and speed. The sword in his hand suddenly glowed red —

"Bloody Sword Strike!"

Sha! The Jade Frog instinctively leaped back, but its movements were too slow when compared to Yuan's sword strike, and it split in half in mid-air, causing organs and blood to fly everywhere.

«You have learned Bloody Sword Strike»

—

«Bloody Sword Strike»

«Rank: Earth»

«Mastery Level: 1»

«Description: Consumes 900 Qi. Must wield a sword to activate. A technique from the Blood Sect.»

«Player Yuan has become the world's first player to have learned an Earth-ranked skill! Congratulations!»

«Player Yuan has become the first player to have killed the Elite Boss: Jade Frog!»

Two announcements appeared, back to back, for the world to see.

After the Jade Frog died, Xiao Hua ran up to Yuan and asked him, "Brother Yuan, where did you learn that technique?"

The sharp aura around Yuan disappeared the moment he heard Xiao Hua's voice. "Hm? Oh, it was a skill used by that red-haired dude fighting in the sky," he said casually.

Xiao Hua silently looked at him with her eyes flickering with admiration. "No wonder Brother Yuan comprehended the Heaven's Secret Art in such a short time..." she mumbled to herself.

"Anyway, I feel like I have gotten stronger from that fight just now. It also felt great to use my body in such a way!" Yuan laughed, "Perhaps I have a talent for fighting? Hahaha!"

"Brother Yuan is a genius, no doubt." Xiao Hua nodded with a serious face.

"Stop it... you're embarrassing me with your flattering..."

"Xiao Hua is not flattering. Brother Yuan's ability to comprehend things is otherworldly. Such talents are rarely seen even in the higher heavens, let alone this Lower Heaven..."

Yuan shook his head, "I was able to beat that frog with ease only because of the powerful sword you gave me. Thank you, Xiao Hua." He patted her head.

"Then when Brother Yuan becomes strong enough, Xiao Hua will give Brother Yuan more powerful weapons!" she said cheerfully.

"You have equipment stronger than this sword? What are you, a walking weapon shop?"

"Un. But Brother Yuan is too weak to wield any of them, so Xiao Hua can only wait until he gets strong enough to wield them without exploding to death."

"E...Exploding to death?" Yuan shivered upon hearing her cruel words. "Surely you must be joking..."

"Unlike normal weapons without a grade, Spirit-grade and above weapons are called Spiritual Weapons that have the ability to gain their own consciousness. If one tries to wield a Spiritual Weapon stronger than their own strength, then the conscious in the weapon may try to kill that person depending on its personality." Xiao Hua explained to him.

"How dangerous... it's almost as if everything in this game will try to kill you if you are too weak..." Yuan thought to himself.

"Weapons, monsters, even humans... it does not matter... if it is strong, then it will dominate the weak. That's why Brother Yuan has to become strong, so he will not be bullied by the strong."

"I will be fine as long as I have you, Xiao Hua." Yuan tried to praise her, but she only turned solemn.

"Brother Yuan, Xiao Hua is only strong in this Lower Heaven... In the higher heavens, Xiao Hua is only an ant when compared to the real experts..." she sighed.

"Only an ant?" Yuan cannot imagine how powerful the cultivators in the higher heavens are when Xiao Hua is already strong enough to destroy an entire mountain.

Xiao Hua suddenly walked away and towards where the dead Jade Frog laid.

"Where are you going?" Yuan followed her.

"When monsters die, some of them will drop a monster core." Xiao Hua shoved her entire arm into the Jade Frog's corpse without flinching and pulled out a small crystal a moment later. "Monster cores are very important to Cultivators because they can greatly assist them in cultivation with Qi stored inside."

"Here you go, Brother Yuan." She handed Yuan the monster core.

"What about you? Don't you also need to grow stronger?" He asked.

"The amount of Qi inside this monster core is too little to have any effect on Xiao Hua, so Brother Yuan should use it."

Yuan nodded, and he threw the monster core into his mouth without hesitation. "Taste like candy..." he thought.

"Ah! Brother Yuan!" Xiao Hua shouted loudly, looking baffled and scared at the same time when she saw Yuan throw the monster core directly into his mouth.

"Hm? What's wrong?" Yuan looked at her casually.

"Monster cores are not meant to be swallowed like that!" she said urgently, "Hurry up and spit it out!"

When Yuan saw her panicking face, he also panicked. What will happen to him now that he ate one?

Cold sweat soaked Yuan's back, but there was nothing he could do because the monster core had melted in his mouth the moment it touched his tongue and have already entered his stomach...

"I... already swallowed it..." Yuan spoke in a stiff tone. "I know it is already too late, but what happens if someone swallows a monster core?"

Xiao Hua dropped to her knees and said, "Monster cores contain the entire cultivation base of its retainer before death, so if someone tries to swallow so much Qi in one go... they will explode to death..."

"Exploding to death again!?" Yuan's jaw dropped from shock. There are too many things in this game that will cause him to explode to death!

Suddenly—

«Heaven Refining Physique activated»

«1,280,000 Qi has been refined from the Jade Frog's monster core»

«You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough»

«You have reached Eighth Level Spirit Apprentice»

«All stats +450»

—

"..."

"..."

"...."

"Brother Yuan, did you just have a breakthrough?" Xiao Hua asked after a long silence, her voice filled with disbelief.

"I did..." he answered with a weird smile.

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Chapter 11 - A Priceless Treasure

Xiao Hua looked at Yuan with a pondering gaze. "Brother Yuan's cultivation base was only at the early stages of Seventh Level Spirit Apprentice before consuming the Jade Frog monster core. Even if Brother Yuan consumes the entire Jade Frog monster core, he shouldn't be able to break through to Eighth Level Spirit Apprentice right away and would only be halfway there..."

"Additionally, Brother Yuan also directly absorbed the entire monster core and did not receive any backlash but had a breakthrough instead... Xiao Hua has never seen anything like this before..."

"Perhaps it had something to do with my physique?" Yuan said.

"Brother Yuan's physique?"

"It's called Heaven Refining Physique," he said, hoping she'd know something about it.

However, Xiao Hua only tilted her head. "Heaven Refining Physique? Xiao Hua has never heard of it before..."

"But if it has something to do with why Brother Yuan was able to consume that Jade Frog monster core, then we can obtain some more monster cores to experiment."

"Hmm..." Yuan suddenly retrieved the token given to him by the goddess during his character evaluation and showed it to her. "Then do you know what this thing is, or its purpose?"

Xiao Hua's eyes instantly widened with shock when she saw the jade token in his hand. "Ancient Spirit Jade! And so big!" she exclaimed loudly,

"Where did Brother Yuan obtain this!?"

"It was given to me by some beauty. I don't know her name, though. What does it do?" Yuan became curious when he saw her shocked expression, looking as though she just witnessed the heavens collapse before her.

"This is a Spirit Jade; it is somewhat similar to a monster core but holds far more Qi within. Even a pebble-sized Royal Spirit Jade of low quality, the lowest grade, is extremely valuable in the higher heavens... since it can awaken or bestow bloodlines..." Xiao Hua forcefully swallowed her saliva and continued, "The Ancient Spirit Jade in Brother Yuan's grasp is three grades above the Royal Spirit Jade... and is probably of high quality... Not to mention it is the size of a palm-sized rock..."

The presence of the Ancient Spirit Jade was enough to make the usually calm Xiao Hua tremble uncontrollably — it was just that valuable of a treasure.

"Hmmm... So I can consume this and obtain Qi like monster cores, right?" Yuan licked his lips when he thought about how sweet the Jade Frog monster core tasted. "I wonder how much stronger I'll grow if I were to eat this..."

Xiao Hua nearly received a heart attack when she heard his words and hastily grabbed his hands. "You mustn't! If Brother Yuan consumes this, even if you have a unique physique, you will surely explode to death! Even a peak Spirit Emperor would not dare to imagine consuming it!"

Yuan chuckled when he saw the anxious face she made, "Relax, Xiao Hua. I won't consume it. Such a valuable item, how could I consume it before I find that beauty to ask her why she gave me this Spirit Jade?"

'For that person to have this Ancient Spirit Jade, she must have a shocking background... Maybe someone from the Supreme Heaven?' Xiao Hua thought to herself.

"Xiao Hua, here."

"?"

"!!!"

Xiao Hua's soul nearly abandoned her body when Yuan suddenly threw the Ancient Spirit Jade at her. Barely catching it, she looked at him with a baffled expression. "Brother Yuan...?"

"It'd be wiser if you were to keep this Ancient Spirit Jade for me until I become strong enough to protect it," he said.

"Xiao Hua cannot hold something this valuable!" She instantly refused while shaking her head, her hands already trembling from the invisible weight coming from the Ancient Spirit Jade.

Yuan frowned, "If you don't want to hold it, then who will? I am aware of my weak existence in this vast world, so having me hold something like that will only bring endless trouble. If I could, I would just throw it away, but now that I know its value... You know what I mean, right?"

Xiao Hua clenched her fist and nodded with a serious expression. "Xiao Hua vows to protect this Ancient Spirit Jade even at the cost of her life!"

"Wrong!" Yuan said loudly. "No matter how valuable that Spirit Jade is, it is only an object and will never be as valuable as your life! If it ever comes to losing your life or that Spirit Jade, then you will choose to lose the Spirit Jade!"

"But..."

"No buts! This is an order!" Yuan was adamant about his decision. In his eyes, there is nothing in this world that can be as valuable as Xiao Hua's life.

"...Xiao Hua understands..." She reluctantly nodded before storing the Ancient Spirit Jade in her storage pouch.

With the Ancient Spirit Jade gone from her sight, the atmosphere was no longer as heavy and suffocating.

'I was unable to learn more about that beauty or why she'd give me such a valuable treasure... How unfortunate.' Yuan sighed inwardly.

"Where do we go to obtain more monster cores?" Yuan asked her with the steel sword still in his grasp, his blood still heated from the battle with the Jade Frog.

"Any monster with a cultivation base of Seventh Level Spirit Apprentice and above will have a chance to drop a monster core," she said.

"Then what are we waiting for? Let's get hunting!"

Xiao Hua began leading Yuan around to find monsters for him to fight. With her cultivation base, it was an easy job for her to locate monsters within a thousand-meter radius.

"There's a middle-level monster 200 meters to the north."

Low-level are monsters between levels one to three, middle-level between levels four to six, and high-level are monsters between levels seven to nine.

"Eh? If it isn't at least at a Seventh Level, what point is there for us to hunt them if they don't drop monster cores?"

"Brother Yuan, no matter how talented an individual is or how many heavenly techniques they have, without the experience to use them properly, they will still be regarded as someone weak."

"I cannot argue against that..." Yuan nodded.

Thus, the two began slaughtering every monster that crossed paths with them... or more precisely, every monster that was unfortunate enough to be in that area.

Chapter 12 - Heaven

«Player Fire Red, Player Poisoned Fiend, Player Mad Dog, and Player Get Creamed has become the first players to have cleared Burning Cave for the first time! Congratulations!»

An announcement hung above the clouds as Yuan elegantly danced around with the steel sword in his grasp, quickly decapitating the four silver wolves surrounding him. The wolf corpses plummeted to the ground, but Yuan did not stop his sword movements and continued to dance, slaying the two wolves that were trying to run.

Xiao Hua, who was watching him at a distance clapped, like a spectator watching a street performance. "Brother Yuan's growth is simply astonishing, like a sponge absorbing water, he easily comprehends everything from his own weakness to his strength. In just a few mere hours, his swordsmanship and Qi manipulation has increased by leaps and bounds."

Her gaze suddenly flickered with regret. "If only Brother Yuan grew up in Supreme Heaven instead of this Lower Heaven where the Qi lacks in both quality and quantity..."

After slaying the last silver wolf, Yuan retrieved all monster cores he had collected during this grind.

"Only seven had dropped after killing dozens of monsters, huh." Yuan cried inwardly at the small amount of monster core he has obtained after spending so much time and effort into slaying monsters.

"Seven monster cores is considered a pretty successful hunt..." Xiao Hua said to him upon seeing his disappointment. "If used properly, seven

monster cores can last a month of cultivation."

"But in Brother Yuan's case..."

"This wouldn't even last a minute for me, let alone one month!" Yuan suddenly throws one into his mouth, and sure enough, it startled Xiao Hua again.

«Heaven Refining Physique activated»

«560,000 Qi has been refined from the Silver Needle Wolf's monster core»

«You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough»

«You have reached Ninth Level Spirit Apprentice»

«All stats +500»

1,519,395/3,840,000

—

"Brother Yuan... you..." Xiao Hua looked at Yuan like he was a ghost, her gaze filled with shock and bewilderment.

"Taste like candy." Yuan licked his lips and said, "Although it did not have as much Qi as the Jade Frog's monster core, it is still very beneficial towards my cultivation."

"B...B...Brother Yuan..." Xiao Hua called him, but she didn't know what to say after that.

"What's wrong?" He looked at her with an innocent gaze, seemingly unaware of how amazing his ability is.

"When a cultivator absorbs the Qi within a monster core, they can only absorb a limited amount of Qi from the monster core depending on the quality of the monster core. However, even a high-grade monster core will only allow one to absorb at most 50% of its total Qi before the rest

dissipates back into the world. This is a rule set by Heaven itself and cannot be defied. But... from Brother Yuan's situation... perhaps his Heaven Refining Physique can ignore this rule and defy the Heavens?" Xiao Hua trembled at the thought that Yuan could possibly have a heaven-defying physique.

"Defying the heavens, huh..." Yuan thought of his real body in real life. "If only I had such an ability in my other life, too..." he sighed inwardly.

Suddenly, Xiao Hua turned her head, and her gaze narrowed. "Brother Yuan, there are people near us..."

'Hm? People? Are they players or NPCs?' He wondered. Since this will be his first encounter with other people besides Xiao Hua since he started playing this game, he wanted to see them.

"Three people — two Seventh Level Spirit Apprentice and one Eighth Level Spirit Apprentice, and they are fighting a peak-level Fiery Lizard."

"I am interested," said Yuan. "Let's go take a look."

"Un."

—

Three young adults, two male, and one female stood a few meters away from a giant lizard with red scales that had black lines spread across like burn marks from a lightning strike. Their gaze flickered continuously with fear and nervousness, and underneath their clothes was a body covered in sweat. They have been fighting this Fiery Lizard for many minutes, yet none of them was able to break through this Fiery Lizard's defense.

"Shit! This thing's scale is as hard as steel! Senior apprentice-brother Mo, we need to leave now before we exhaust our Qi!"

"Junior apprentice-brother Wang is right! We cannot beat this beast with our current abilities! Let's leave before it's too late!"

The eldest among the three there, Mo Zhou, bit his lips as he stared at the Fiery Lizard before him. He has already exhausted all his techniques on this Fiery Lizard, yet there were only scratches on the surface of its scales. "I refuse!" he suddenly shouted.

"Senior apprentice-brother Mo!" The other two became anxious when they saw the stubbornness on his face.

"You two can leave, but I will stay here until either one of us dies! My life depends on this Fiery Lizard's monster core!" Mo Zhou bit his lips until it bled, but he continued to look at the Fiery Lizard with narrowed eyes filled with determination. "Either I die here or I return to the sect and die there! Since I will die either way, I might as well put everything on the line at this moment!"

"Then die here! I only helped you out of pity!" said the male before he turned to run away from the fight.

"This wouldn't be happening if you didn't offend Senior apprentice-brother Ren!" The female also abandoned the fight. Neither of those two was willing to risk their lives for him despite being friends for many years.

Mo Zhou sighed at his junior apprentice sister's words. "Junior apprentice-sister Ling is right... but I couldn't ignore my heart no matter what... not even knowing that I will be offending a Chosen by doing so..." He lifted his sword once again to face the Fiery Lizard. "Come, you trash!"

—

"Hmm? Xiao Hua, you said that there were three, but why is there only one here?" Yuan pointed at Mo Zhou, who was fighting the Fiery Lizard with fierce eyes and a bloodied robe.

"They left before we could arrive," she replied calmly.

"What about him? Do you think he'll win?"

Xiao Hua shook her head. "His cultivation base is almost dried up; it will only be a matter of time before he collapses due to Qi Deprivation."

"He is the only other person I have met so far besides you, Xiao Hua. It'd be a shame if he were to die here..." Yuan suddenly jumped into the fight with his sword raised. "Bloody Sword Strike!"

The Spirit Sword easily penetrated the unsuspected Fiery Lizard's steel-like scales and directly pierced its heart, instantly killing it with one strike. "Are you okay?" Yuan looked at the dazed Mo Zhou, who was staring at him like a dumb chicken, his mouth wide open and all.

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Chapter 13 - Flying Sword Sec

"T...T...T...This..." Mo Zhou stuttered like a baby who just started speaking. He has never seen anyone penetrate the scales of a Fiery Lizard known for its nearly impenetrable defense with a single sword strike, let alone with such ease!

Yuan suddenly extended his hand for Mo Zhou, who had fallen to the ground from shock. "So? Why did you continue to fight that thing despite the obvious conclusion?" he asked as he pulled Mo Zhou off the ground.

Mo Zhou's expression stiffened upon hearing his question. "I will die if I fail to obtain a Fiery Lizard monster core, so I might as well die trying..." he sighed in a sorrowful tone.

"Why would you die if you cannot obtain one?" Yuan became interested in his situation.

Taking another deep sigh, Mo Zhou said, "Because I had offended a Chosen from my sect..."

"Chosen? What's that?"

Mo Zhou looked at him with a weird expression. How can anyone not know what a Chosen means?

"A Chosen is someone who is favored by the mighty heaven; they are all born with great talents and are respected by everyone."

"Favored by the heavens, huh..." Yuan nodded, "So you mean to tell me that you are going to die because you had offended this one guy? What did you do, kill his parents in front of him?"

Mo Zhou shook his head violently at his words. "No way! All I did was court senior apprentice-sister Xing... but because senior apprentice-brother Ren also fancies her... my actions angered him..."

"Are they dating?"

"No..."

"Aiya!" Yuan facepalmed, making a loud slapping sound. "He wants to kill you because you went ahead and confessed your love to this Xing girl? What kind of unreasonable man is this senior apprentice-brother Ren of yours?"

Mo Zhou became dumbfounded by his words. "But... this type of situation happens all the time...?" he thought to himself.

Yuan glanced at the Fiery Lizard corpse. "You need that, right?" he asked while pointing.

"...Yes."

"Take it."

"Eh?" Mo Zhou looked at him with a face full of surprise. This Fiery Lizard monster core is no doubt a valuable treasure that even the sect elders would covet, yet this young man was willing to give it to him, who he just met, just like that?

"Really...?" Mo Zhou mumbled in a doubtful tone. "But it was you who killed it..."

"Then I'll just take it for myself—" Yuan turned to walk towards the corpse.

Seeing his actions, Mo Zhou quickly panicked. "Wait! I want – No, please let me have it! I, Mo Zhou of the Flying Sword Sect, will be forever in your debt!"

"Brother Yuan is really kind. If it were anybody else, they would have definitely kept it for themselves." Xiao Hua thought to herself as she

watched Mo Zhou fall to his knees to kowtow to Yuan as a way to show his gratitude.

"If there is anything this savior needs from this Mo Zhou, he will do it without fail!" Mo Zhou said loudly with tears falling off the corner of his eyes.

Having never been in such a situation, Yuan didn't know how to react to Mo Zhou's actions. "No need to be so humble. If I can exchange a mere monster core for someone's life, of course, I will do it without hesitation," he said.

"Thank you! Thank you very much..." Mo Zhou stayed kowtowing. "Not only did you already save me once from the Fiery Lizard... you are also giving me this Fiery Lizard monster core... In such a short time, you have already saved my life twice! Please, accept this as my gratitude..."

"It is awkward seeing a grown man such as yourself in this position while crying... hurry and stand up already..."

—

It took a moment, but Mo Zhou eventually calmed down.

"I haven't gotten your name..."

"You can call me Yuan."

"Then, fellow Daoist Yuan, once again, I am Mo Zhou, an outer disciple of the Flying Sword Sect." Mo Zhou stretched his hands for a handshake.

"Flying Sword Sect? What's a sect, again?" Yuan asked, forgetting that he'd already heard of such a word when he first arrived in this world.

Mo Zhou instantly became dazed at his question.

"Brother Yuan, a Sect is an organization dedicated to the practices of cultivation, where people go to study cultivation." Xiao Hua explained to him.

"So in other words... a school for cultivators?" Yuan looked at Mo Zhou, and a profound light flashed in his eyes. "Hey, Mo Zhou, can you give me a tour around your Flying Sword Sect? I have never been to a sect before, you see..."

Mo Zhou trembled, waking up from his daze. "So you really are a rogue cultivator..." he mumbled in a voice of disbelief.

"Rogue cultivator?" Yuan looked at Xiao Hua with a question mark floating on the top of his head.

"They are independent cultivators that do not belong to any sect."

"Oh, I understand. But why do you look so shocked?" He turned to look at Mo Zhou.

"I can tell that Daoist Yuan is a Ninth Level Spirit Apprentice, but he was able to slay that Fiery Lizard that even Third Level Spirit Warriors would have trouble, and you even killed it with such ease..."

"What he is trying to say is Brother Yuan, who does not have the support of Sects, shouldn't be this powerful," Xiao Hua intervened.

She looked at the dumbfounded Mo Zhou and said, "Brother Yuan is special. Don't compare him with these geniuses. Even these so-called Chosen are nothing in front of Brother Yuan."

"Ah, you are making me blush with such a bashful statement..." Yuan sighed in a low voice, his face slightly red.

"No – as arrogant as it may have sounded, I believe it... that Daoist Yuan is no doubt a genius." Mo Zhou said with a serious expression. "As for visiting my Flying Sword Sect... I will have to get permission from my sect elder before I can say for sure..."

"Really? Then what are we waiting for?" Yuan said cheerfully. He didn't expect that he'd have the chance to go to school in a video game, something

he did not have the luxury of doing in the real world due to the limitations on his body.

"Ah! Give me a second to retrieve the monster core..." Mo Zhou said hastily, nearly forgetting about it.

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Chapter 14 - Thousand Swords Formation

"Bloody Sword Strike!"

A red arc of light swept through the forest and directly beheaded the three meters tall ape without alerting it.

«Your comprehension with Bloody Sword Strike has reached a new level»

«Bloody Sword Strike Mastery Level (1) → (2)»

«Bloody Sword Strike»

«Rank: Earth»

«Mastery Level: 2»

«Description: Consumes 90,000 Qi. Must wield a sword to activate. A technique from the Blood Sect.»

When Yuan noticed how the Qi consumption had increased a hundred folds with a single mastery level increase, his jaw dropped from shock. Wouldn't his Heaven Splitting Sword Strike require one million Qi to activate at mastery level 2 at this rate?

"Fellow Daoist Yuan is really... incomprehensible..." Mo Zhou trembled in shock as he watched Yuan slay high-level monsters with ease, and all in a single strike. "Even that high-level Spirit Apprentice Bull Ape was slain in a single strike..."

Ever since they met and decided to visit the Flying Sword Sect, Yuan would hunt down every monster in their path, collecting a few more monster cores.

"Eleven so far, huh..." Yuan counted the number of monster cores he had obtained, and the bundle of glistening monster cores in Yuan's grasp dumbfounded Mo Zhou to the core, who thought he was in an auction house.

"So many monster cores!"

Mo Zhou exclaimed loudly. Monster cores are all valuable resources that greatly assist cultivators with their cultivation, and they are greatly desired by cultivators from all levels. And because they can only be acquired through high-level monsters, they are considered rare and hard to obtain. But now in front of his eyes, there are a dozen of them all gathered on one man's palm.

"You consider this many? It won't even fill the gap between my teeth if I eat them all..." Yuan sighed.

"What?"

Mo Zhou couldn't comprehend the meaning behind his words, but he had a premonition that he would regret it if he knew, so he decided to ignore it.

—

"We have been running into a lot of high-level monsters, haven't we? That was already the sixth one..." Mo Zhou pondered as another high-level monster falls to the ground with its head detached from its neck.

"You really like beheading things..."

"It's efficient and easy, after all." Yuan smiled casually: "Tch. No monster core from this one..."

"Easy, huh..."

Mo Zhou inwardly compared Yuan with the Chosen in his sect. Would they be able to say such bold words so casually? Would they also be able to behead high-level monsters with such ease? Most likely not.

A thought suddenly appeared in Mo Zhou's head: 'Since he is a rogue cultivator... there is a chance I can rope him into joining our Flying Sword Sect...?'

If the Flying Sword Sect accepted a genius like him into their ranks, they will surely be overjoyed. Hell, they may even consider him a candidate as a future Sect Leader!

"Say, Daoist Yuan... have you ever considered joining a Sect?" he decided to ask him.

Yuan thought about it for a moment and shook his head: "I did not know of the existence of these so-called 'Sects' until today, so no, I have never thought about it."

"Then... would you be interested in joining my Flying Sword Sect? I am sure the Sect will welcome you with wide arms."

"..."

While Yuan pondered, Xiao Hua decided to open her mouth and speak: "Brother Yuan, there is no need for you to join a Sect; it will only hinder your growth. Xiao Hua believes that Brother Yuan will grow stronger much faster when together with Xiao Hua as a rogue cultivator."

Mo Zhou's mouth dropped when he heard Xiao Hua's words. Because she has been silent, he didn't really pay much attention to her. He wondered about their relationship.

"If I ever join a Sect, it'd only be for fun," said Yuan. "However, it is still too early for me to join any Sect, so I will have to refuse that offer for now."

"Is that so..."

While Mo Zhou was dispirited due to Yuan refusing his offer, he understood that there was still hope for him to join the Flying Sword Sect in the future. "Then, if you ever feel like joining a sect, please come to my Flying Sword Sect."

"I'll keep that in mind."

—

After walking for a few more hours, the group finally arrived at a vast valley surrounded by high mountains.

"This is the Flying Sword Sect?" Yuan was mesmerized by the scene of the thousand swords hovering in the air above the valley, looking as though there was a roof made of swords covering the place.

"That's the Thousand Swords Formation; it is a Heaven-ranked battle formation. If activated, they will all attack at once, like a rain of arrows. Though, it has been over 100 years since it was last activated." Mo Zhou wanted to leave a deep impression on Yuan with the Sect's power, hoping it would increase the chances of him join the Sect.

Mo Zhou's words and the magnificent scene indeed left a deep impression within Yuan, who has never seen anything like this before. As for Xiao Hua, she only glanced at it for a second before looking away.

"Please wait here for a moment while I go ask for permission to give you a tour around as a guest."

"Un." Yuan nodded and waited outside for him.

—

"A genius rogue cultivator, you say?" An old man sat in his exquisite wooden chair, his gaze as the young man standing before him.

"That's right, Elder Jiang. He managed to slay a high-level Fiery Lizard with a single sword strike, even piercing its steel-like scales known for its

impenetrable defense!" Mo Zhou shared his experience with Yuan to the old man before him.

The old man was Elder Jiang, a sect elder of the Flying Sword Sect, who was also in charge of the administration for the sect.

"If this young man is really as good as you praised him to be, then I'd like to meet him myself." Elder Jiang stood up and walked towards the door. "What are you waiting for? Let's go."

"Yes!"

Mo Zhou led Elder Jiang outside the sect where Yuan and Xiao Hua waited patiently.

"Fellow Daoist Yuan! Thank you for waiting... umm..."

"Hmm... Ninth Level Spirit Apprentice... how old are you, young man?" Elder Jiang could tell Yuan's cultivation base with a single glance.

"You seem to be around Mo Zhou's age... not bad for a rogue cultivator who cultivated without any proper guidance." He nodded with approval.

"You are...?"

"This is Elder Jiang, he is in charge of the sect's administrations for the Outer Court disciples." Mo Zhou introduced Elder Jiang to Yuan.

"I see. Nice to meet you, Elder Jiang."

Elder Jiang gently brushed his white beard and said, "I will get straight to the point, do you want to join my Flying Sword Sect as a disciple? The Sect provides countless benefits and resources to its disciples to help them grow. If you join, then your cultivation base will definitely rise faster than before. Perhaps you may even qualify to become an Inner Court disciple one day."

"Inner Court disciple?" Yuan wondered if Inner Court disciples meant being something like an upperclassman.

"You..."

Elder Jiang frowned and looked at Mo Zhou.

"Elder Jiang, you see... Daoist Yuan has actually never been aware of the existence of sects until today, hence why he wanted to visit our Flying Sword Sect..." Mo Zhou explained to him with a bitter smile.

"What...? How is that even possible?" Elder Jiang doubted his words, but even an idiot could come up with a better excuse.

Elder Jiang looked at Yuan again, and he sighed. "Whatever. I do not care about your circumstances. Well? What is your answer? I will accept you as an Outer Court disciple right this moment if you so wish."

Mo Zhou saw the chance and urged Yuan. "Daoist Yuan, you are really lucky! Under normal circumstances, one would have to pass the entrance exam before they get admitted into the sect as a disciple. However, Elder Jiang here has the authority to accept you into the sect without any of that hassle! This is a once-in-a-lifetime chance that anyone would be willing to die for!" he said with excitement.

"..." Yuan turned silent for a moment.

However, despite the enticing offer, Yuan still shook his head. "Although I appreciate the gracious offer, I will have to decline..."

"Why?!" Mo Zhou exclaimed. How could anybody let such a chance go to waste? This could be his ticket to becoming an Inner Court disciple of a great sect such as the Flying Sword Sect – a chance every Outer Court disciple like Mo Zhou would die for!

"Like I have already said... I am not yet ready to join any factions. I am currently waiting for someone, and until she arrives, I will not make any big decisions," said Yuan.

Xiao Hua glanced at Yuan when he mentioned that he was waiting for someone. Who could this person be?

"..."

"..."

"...Very well..." Elder Jiang said with his eyes closed, "If that is your decision then so be it. However... do not come back one day and ask for my generosity again as you have already lost it once."

Mo Zhou sighed. All of his efforts were wasted in such a short amount of time. Perhaps the reason Elder Jiang did not put any real effort into pursuing Yuan was that he still doesn't fully trust his words – that Yuan was a prodigy that even Inner Court disciples may not be able to match.

"Umm... about the tour... am I still allowed to see your sect?" Yuan asked with a sly expression; he still wanted to see the inside even after all that he's said.

Mo Zhou looked at Elder Jiang with the corner of his eyes, waiting for his answer.

Elder Jiang coldly snorted and said, "Let him see what he's missed out."

He walked away afterward.

"..."

Yuan was speechless. Refusing Elder Jiang's offer must have offended him.

Mo Zhou sighed again and said with an apologetic expression, "Don't worry about it too much, Daoist Yuan. It was my fault to begin with... If I hadn't spoken so highly of you in front of Elder Jiang with the intention of recruiting you then this would've never have happened."

Yuan shook it off and said, "I don't mind it. He's just a grumpy old man, after all."

"G-Grumpy old man... Daoist Yuan... please don't ever let him hear you say that in front of him or else he will definitely kill you..." Mo Zhou, with a

terrified expression, turned to see whether or not Elder Jiang had heard Yuan. When he couldn't see Elder Jiang's figure, Mo Zhou sighed in relief.

"Forget about him and let's hurry and go inside. I have been itching to see the inside since the sight of the Thousand Sword Formations!" Yuan said in an urging tone.

Mo Zhou smiled bitterly and said, "Alright... follow me..." He turned around and led the two inside, where disciples could be seen bustling around.

"Wow... they all carry swords with them..." Yuan's eyes flickered with excitement. He couldn't be more excited at this moment. In his eyes, this place was just begging for him to explore!

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Chapter 15 - The Stone Tablets

"That building over there is the cafeteria for Outer Court disciples like me. The Inner Court disciples eat at a separate building." Mo Zhou explained as he guided Yuan around the Flying Sword Sect.

"Un. Un." Yuan nodded his head in excitement.

"Do you see that open area over there? That is where disciples go for lectures from Sect Elders once a week."

"That tall building is where disciples train to sharpen their sword techniques," said Mo Zhou as he pointed to the pagoda that was in the distance.

"What a unique shape for a building..." Yuan silently admired the elegant tower.

"Do you think I can go inside for a closer look?" he then asked Mo Zhou, who quickly shook his head in an apologetic manner.

"I'm sorry, Daoist Yuan, but visitors are not allowed inside any building with a ceiling..."

"Che. What a stinky place. How will you attract new disciples if you block off everything?" Yuan shook his head in pity.

"Uhh..." Mo Zhou didn't know how to refute his ignorant statement and could only smile awkwardly. Because normally, one wouldn't tour around a Sect before deciding whether they want to join or not.

"Forget it." Yuan suddenly said. "Let's continue with the tour."

Mo Zhou heaved a sigh of relief when Yuan didn't continue the topic.

"Okay, then let me show you what disciples of the Flying Sword Sect deem as the most important thing in this Sect!"

"Ohh?"

Hearing his words, Yuan instantly became curious about this place.

After walking for a few minutes, they stopped in front of three tall stone tablets sitting beside each other.

These three stone tablets were perfectly rectangular and had dozens of names engraved on it, resembling a memorial for the dead. However, unlike the other two, the middle stone tablet only had a few names on it, and they were much bigger and sharper than the rest.

"What's this? A memorial for the dead?" Yuan opened his mouth to ask without thinking.

"Wha—" Mo Zhou looked at him with a scared look. He then looked around to see if anybody was there to hear his words.

After seeing that the place was empty, Mo Zhou heaved another sigh of relief.

"Daoist Yuan, even though I am aware of your ignorance about Sects, what you'd just said had greatly offended not only me but also every disciple in this Sect!"

"What?" Yuan looked at him with a baffled expression.

"This is not a memorial for the dead but a ranking for the entire Sect! Every name on these three tablets represents a genius within the Sect, and they are all respected by the thousands of disciples in this Sect! If others besides me had heard your words, they would've jumped at you with their swords raised, as that was extremely disrespectful to the individuals that have poured their sweat and blood just to be on that ranking!"

"I-Is that right? I had no idea, but I will still apologize for my rude remarks... Sorry." Yuan said in an apologetic tone.

Seeing his sincere apology, Mo Zhou nodded with an approving smile. "It's fine. I know you didn't mean it."

He then turned to the three stone tablets again and said: "Every stone tablet except the middle one holds forty-five names, with the middle having only ten, adding up to a total of one hundred names."

"These hundred names are the names of the strongest disciples within the Flying Sword Sect— not including the Sect Elders and the Sect Leader. And every single one of them receives the Sect's full backing, allowing them to enjoy almost an unlimited amount of resources provided by the Sect. Ah... and everybody in the middle stone tablets is given the title 'Core Disciple'."

Mo Zhou's eyes sparkled with admiration as he stared at the three stone tablets, especially when his gaze met with the middle one, seemingly mesmerized.

"Every disciple in this Sect— including me— desires to have our own names engraved on the stone tablet."

Suddenly, as Mo Zhou ended his words, the last name on the third stone tablet disappeared. And a few seconds later, another name engraved itself on the very same spot.

When Mo Zhou saw this, his eyes flickered with excitement.

"Look! Someone just replaced the 100th name!"

"Eh? How did the names on the tablet change itself? Aren't they engraved into it?" Yuan was more curious about the phenomenon than the event itself.

—

After staring at the stone tablet for a few moments, Yuan suddenly noticed the name 'Ren Fuchen'.

He pointed to the first stone tablet and asked Mo Zhou in a curious tone: "Hey, that Ren Fuchen... is he the same as the Ren that you had offended?"

When Yuan mentioned Ren Fuchen, Mo Zhou's complexion noticeably paled.

He then nodded in a dispirited motion, confirming Yuan's curiosity.

"His name is ranked... 14th. He's the 14th strongest disciple in this place?"

Mo Zhou nodded again but even slower this time.

"What about the girl you were courting? Is she also on the ranking?"

Hearing his question, Mo Zhou silently pointed to the last name engraved on the middle stone tablet.

"Xing Aiying... ranked 10th..." Yuan then turned to look at Mo Zhou with a surprised look. "You actually courted someone that has her name on the ranking — the middle one, no less? How bold and aspiring!"

"..."

Mo Zhou could only smile bitterly at Yuan's words that were seemingly filled with admiration and praise.

"Anyway, this is pretty much all there is to see, for guests like you at least," Mo Zhou said.

"Now I have to give this Fiery Lizard monster core to senior apprentice-brother Ren..." Mo Zhou sighed in a dejected manner.

"Do you really have to give it to him? You didn't do anything wrong, so there's no reason for you to listen to his nonsense," said Yuan.

Mo Zhou shook his head and said, "You don't understand, Daoist Yuan. This is a world where the strong makes the rules and the weak obey their rules, even if such rules are unreasonable and full of nonsense."

"And I'm telling you that only an idiot would follow such rules," Yuan shrugged. "You are the one who doesn't understand here."

"A-An idiot?" Mo Zhou looked at him, who'd unknowingly called everybody in this world an idiot, with a weird expression on his face.

"How about I come with you to meet this Ren guy?" Yuan suddenly said, dumbfounding him.

"It's fine," Mo Zhou said a moment later with a bitter smile, "This is my own problem, I cannot drag you into it, especially not after all that you've done for me already."

Yuan turned silent and looked at him with a calm expression.

"Is that so? Then—"

Suddenly, a loud voice resounded from the distance.

"Hey, isn't that the kid who tried to court senior apprentice-sister Xing and ended up offending you?"

Both Yuan and Mo Zhou turned to look in the direction of the voice, and Mo Zhou's face paled the instant he saw the two handsome young men in the distance looking at him.

"S-Senior apprentice-brother Ren! Senior apprentice-brother Zhen!"

When Yuan saw how Mo Zhou's legs were shaking like jello, he knew just how fearful he was towards these two individuals.

"Mo Zhou, you bastard! How dare you make me walk to your living quarters to look for you!" The handsome young man on the right approached Mo Zhou with an angry expression, his hands grasped tightly into fists.

"Where have you been hiding? Didn't I say that today was the last day for you to bring me a monster core from a Fiery Lizard or else—?!"

"I have it! I have a Fiery Lizard monster core with me! Here you go!"

Mo Zhou pulled out a small red crystal from his robe pockets and showed it to Ren Fuchen.

'That brat really managed to obtain a Fiery Lizard monster core!' Ren Fuchen's eyes widened upon seeing the crystal. He did not think that someone as weak as Mo Zhou would have the ability to slay a powerful beast like the Fiery Lizard, yet there was its monster core in his grasp.

"How did you get it? Don't tell me you bought it?"

"It doesn't matter how I obtained it! I have gotten what you asked, so leave me alone from now on!"

"Hahahaha!" Hearing his words, Ren Fuchen burst out laughing. "You really are an idiot! You really think that I'd leave you alone just because you somehow managed to obtain the monster core? That was only an excuse for me to beat you up!"

"What?!" At this point, Mo Zhou's heart was filled with bitterness. "You promised that you'd forget about me courting senior apprentice-sister Xing if I give you the Fiery Lizard monster core!"

"Of course, I will honor my words and forget about your disgraceful act of courting senior apprentice-sister Xing. However, after you give me the Fiery Lizard, it will no longer be about that. How dare a lowly trash such as yourself have feelings for senior apprentice-sister Xing! Just your feelings are enough for you to get beaten!"

Mo Zhou trembled uncontrollably upon hearing those words. Just his love for his senior apprentice-sister Xing is enough to get beaten? Where is the justice in that? But alas, he was weak and Ren Fuchen was a Chosen — their status in this world was simply too far apart.

"Wow, what a statement!" Yuan suddenly said loudly, causing Mo Zhou's body to mysteriously stop trembling. "Beating someone up just because they love the same person as you? What a messed up personality you have there." Yuan laughed out loud, almost like he was watching a funny movie.

"And who the fuck are you? You are clearly not a disciple of this Sect, so how did you get in here?" Ren Fuchen finally noticed Yuan and Xiao Hua standing by the side.

"Who am I? I am the person who gave him that Fiery Lizard monster core," said Yuan, his expression calm.

"Daoist Yuan!" Mo Zhou looked at him with wide eyes.

"Hoh? So you are the one..." Ren Fuchen looked at Yuan with narrowed eyes.

"Why did you give him something as precious as the Fiery Lizard monster core? What did he offer in return?" he asked.

"He didn't give me anything, nor do I want anything from him. I gave him it simply because I felt like it," Yuan casually replied.

"..."

Although he didn't know who Yuan was, Ren Fuchen was wary of him. After all, what kind of normal individual would give away something as valuable as a Fiery Lizard monster core for free?

"And? What do you want?"

"I'd appreciate it if you stop bullying him," said Yuan with a smile.

"And what if I said no?" While Ren Fuchen didn't want to offend someone as mysterious as him, he wasn't afraid of him. Not only is he a Chosen but they are still inside the Flying Sword Sect, where he has protection in every direction.

"Of course, you will refuse...." Yuan turned to look at Mo Zhou and said, "I have already saved his life once, it won't be weird if I do it again, right?"

"You..." Ren Fuchen instantly frowned at his words.

"Daoist Yuan!" As for Mo Zhou, he looked at Yuan with tears in his eyes, his gaze filled with admiration, and his heart filled with gratitude.

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Chapter 16 - A Battle Maniac

"I do not know which hole you crawled from, but consider this is your last warning!" Ren Fuchen said as he unsheathed the sword by his side, causing the aura around him to change.

Yuan looked at Ren Fuchen with a smile. Instead of worrying that he might have to fight another human for the first time, he actually found this situation to be pretty entertaining.

"You wanna fight? Let's go! I have been wanting to test my sword on something that's not monster for once!" Yuan also retrieved his sword.

When Ren Fuchen saw Yuan's sword that was emitting a powerful and sharp aura, his eyes widened with shock.

"A Spirit-grade sword... and it's even peak quality! He actually has a peak quality spiritual weapon!"

Any weapons with a grade are considered precious treasures, as they are always many times stronger than normal weapons, especially weapons with higher quality.

And although Yuan's sword is only at the lowest grade, Spirit-grade, a peak quality weapon is something that even someone like Ren Fuchen, who is ranked 14th overall in this entire Sect, does not have.

Ren Fuchen frowned deeply after realizing that Yuan had a peak quality weapon whilst he only held a medium quality weapon. His attitude also changed, and he no longer looked at this situation as calmly as before. After all, he is already at a disadvantage before the fight even started! Compared to Yuan's peak quality weapon, his medium grade quality is akin to a wooden stick!

"What are you standing there for? If you don't want to fight then just say so." Yuan said to him when he doesn't move even after many moments, his voice with a hint of provocation.

'No! Although he has a superior weapon, I have the advantage in terms of Cultivation base! He's only a ninth level Spirit Apprentice whilst I am a fifth level Spirit Warrior! There's no way I could lose even if he has a peak quality weapon!' Ren Fuchen encouraged himself with such logic.

Even if Yuan has a peak quality weapon, if he does not have the Cultivation base to use its full potential, it will actually burden him instead.

"If you hand over that weapon as an apology, then I don't mind forgiving you for everything you've done up to this point, and I will even stop bothering Mo Zhou. How does that sound?"

Before Yuan could even open his mouth to speak, Xiao Hua opened her mouth for the first time, "Brother Yuan, this will be good practice for you. Although you have familiarized yourself with beasts, you have yet to fight another human and to be honest, you will most likely be fighting more humans than beasts in the future."

Yuan nodded and raised his sword to stand in an offensive stance. He had no intention of avoiding this fight, as he already considered this as an in-game event.

"Good! Then I shall take it off your dead body!"

Ren Fuchen roared as he charged towards Yuan with the sword in his grasp raised high in the air.

"Triple Sword Strike!"

Ren Fuchen connected three attacks together in the blink of an eye, making it seem as though he attacked three times with a single movement.

Yuan's eyes widened at his approach, but he was not shocked. Instead, he was watching Ren Fuchen's attack closely, almost as if he was analyzing it.

In the next instant, Yuan raised his sword, blocking all three strikes with a single move.

"What?!"

Ren Fuchen exclaimed in surprise after Yuan perfectly blocked his attack.

However, despite blocking it perfectly, Yuan was pushed back slightly from the power created by someone five whole levels above him.

"Amazing..."

Yuan looked at his trembling hands with a wide smile on his face.

"This tingly and numbing sensation... What a great feeling!"

Yuan, whose real body cannot feel anything, was excited to experience such a feeling for the first time, and it made him feel alive.

"Is he crazy?" Ren Fuchen looked at Yuan's smiling face and thought to himself.

"Come! Let's fight even more!"

It was Yuan's turn to be aggressive this time.

'Could Brother Yuan be a battle maniac?' Xiao Hua wondered to herself.

"Bloody Sword Strike!"

The blade of the sword suddenly glowed red, and killing intent filled the place.

"?!?!?!?!"

Ren Fuchen nearly crapped his pants when he realized that Yuan had just used an Earth-grade sword technique.

"Impossible! You are clearly only a Spirit Apprentice! How could you possibly use an Earth-grade sword technique!" He gasped in shock.

Ren Fuchen hastily raised his sword to block the incoming attack.

Bang!

The moment their swords collided, Ren Fuchen felt as though he was clashing against a mountain, and his knees were forced to the ground by the tyrannical pressure pressing down on him!

The next instant, Ren Fuchen noticed cracks appearing across his sword.

"Not good! At this rate, he will break my weapon!"

"Help me!" he suddenly called out to his fellow disciple that had been on standby.

In the next moment, the disciple retrieved his sword and approached them at high speed.

"Daoist Yuan! Watch out!"

Mo Zhou couldn't react in time to block the disciple and yelled out loud to warn Yuan of the incoming danger.

However, Yuan did not even turn to look at the disciple and swung his sword, throwing Ren Fuchen many meters into the distance.

Once Ren Fuchen was out of the picture, Yuan turned to face the second disciple.

"Bloody Sword Strike!"

He activated the same skill and quickly swung his sword, sending an arc of light towards the surprised disciple.

The disciple, who was not the least prepared for such a strike, could only watch as the arc sped towards his direction and separate one of his limbs.

"AAAAAAHHHHHHHHH!!! MY ARM! MY ARM!!!"

The disciple dropped on the floor and screamed in agony while clutching the right side of his body.

"Oops..."

Yuan had acted purely on instinct and did not really mean to cut off the disciple's arm, even feeling bad for him afterward.

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Chapter 17 - Blood Sec

'H-He should be fine, right? This is just his reaction as an NPC, right? His arm will regrow as if nothing happened after I leave, right?' Yuan tried to convince himself so that he'd feel less guilty for cutting the disciple's arm.

"Y-You bastard! I will fucking kill you!" Ren Fuchen roared in anger, but he was secretly fearful of Yuan's tyrannical strength. Even now, his arms are shaking from Yuan's strike.

"It's not my fault he jumped into our fight," Yuan directed the blame towards the disciple, which caused the disciple to cough up a mouthful of blood upon hearing his words.

"AHHHH! HELP ME! I'M BLEEDING TO DEATH!"

The disciple continued to yell at the top of his lungs, but the nearby disciples did not assist him, as they did not want to be caught up in their ruckus.

Eventually, the disciple's voice reached Elder Jiang's ears, who was sipping tea not too far from the place.

Throwing his tea down, Elder Jiang leaped into the air and approached the noise. The way he jumped from rooftops to rooftops made it seem as though he could control the gravity around him, allowing him to be weightless.

When he arrived, Elder Jiang's eyes widened with shock at the puzzling situation. He then quickly reacted by stopping the blood from spurting out of the disciple's arm.

Once he fixed the problem by placing some sort of seal around the disciple's arm, Elder Jiang wiped the sweat from his forehead and turned to face Mo Zhou.

"What the hell is going on here, Mo Zhou?!"

He directed his anger towards Mo Zhou, who was trying his best not to piss his pants from listening to the disciple's agonizing screams.

"T-T-This... T-They confronted us with hostility, and in order to protect me, Daoist Yuan sparred with senior apprentice-brother Ren... When senior apprentice-brother was on the verge of losing, senior apprentice-brother Huang tried to back-stab Daoist Yuan, which resulted in this situation..."

"Daoist Yuan? That child?!"

Elder Jiang turned to look at Yuan, who was trying to hide the bloody sword in his hand behind his back while awkwardly smiling at him.

"This child, who is only a ninth level Spirit Apprentice, defeated not only Huang Ding but also Ren Fuchen, one of the top Inner Court disciples?"

Elder Jiang couldn't believe his ears. Although Cultivators achieving victory against people with a higher Cultivation base is not that uncommon, such a large skip in level is unheard of!

"It doesn't matter who is right or wrong here right now, but is this how you repay my generosity for letting you inside as a guest? I don't care what background you came from, prepare to face the consequences for attacking a disciple of the Flying Sword Sect!"

Elder Jiang began approaching Yuan, who felt something amiss here. They are clearly the ones in the wrong for confronting him, and he even defended one of their disciples from getting bullied, yet he's going to be punished?

Sure, he did slice that disciple's arm off, but that was an accident that could've been prevented if he didn't jump in the middle of their match.

"It doesn't matter who is right or wrong? Although I do not belong here, don't I have the right to be safe as a guest in your house? One of your students provoked me into fighting him, but you don't care about that. Your own students are being bullied by their fellow students in plain sight, yet nobody even bothered to prevent it. If this is how you act as a teacher of this place, then I don't think you should be a teacher!" Yuan said what was on his mind without saving any face for Elder Jiang.

"How dare you! Who are you to lecture me?!" Elder Jiang's eyes turned red from anger, clearly provoked by Yuan's words.

Seeing Elder Jiang emit faint killing intent, Xiao Hua also silently prepared herself. If Elder Jiang so much as tries to hurt Yuan, she will not hesitate to kill him.

Just as Elder Jiang prepared himself to punish Yuan for speaking out of line, a sudden voice resounded in his ears.

"Wait."

Elder Jiang instantly halted his movements and turned to look behind him.

When he saw that it was a middle-aged man with sharp features and a dominating presence standing behind him, his eyes widened with shock.

"S-Sect Leader!"

Not only Elder Jiang but everybody there exclaimed loudly.

"Step back, Elder Jiang. I will personally take care of this."

"What?!"

Elder Jiang was shocked speechless, but he didn't dare refuse and silently nodded.

Once Elder Jiang stepped back, the Sect Leader stepped forward.

He then looked at Ren Fuchen and Huang Ding and spoke, "I have been watching since the beginning."

His words dumbfounded the two, causing them to tremble in fear.

"How pathetic. Not only did you lose a two on one but you also had the audacity to attempt a back-stab. Where did you learn to fight like cowards? I do not recall teaching this type of swordsmanship in my Sect! I will surely discipline both of you afterward."

Ren Fuchen's expression paled upon hearing the Sect Leader's words. Knowing his character, they will surely be experiencing hell after this. As for Huang Ding, he directly fell unconscious after hearing the Sect Leader's words.

"What is your response?!" The Sect Leader suddenly roared.

"Y-Yes, Sect Leader!" Ren Fuchen replied in a cracked voice.

"Hmph." The Sect Leader coldly snorted.

He then turned to look at Yuan. "That technique you used just now... You must be from the Blood Sect."

'The Blood Sect?! That evil place?!' Elder Jiang cried inwardly.

He didn't expect someone innocent-looking like Yuan to be apart of that vile place! If he'd known, he would have never allowed him inside this place!

"I do not want any trouble with you or your place, so please just leave us alone. As for this incident, it was our fault, so you don't have to worry about anything."

"..."

Everybody there was speechless watching their domineering Sect Leader act so humble before someone way younger. Not many of them even have heard of this Blood Sect, so they were also puzzled.

"Uhhh..." Yuan was also speechless. He didn't expect the situation to make such a turn and was at a loss of what to do.

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Chapter 18 - Mo Zhou's Gratitude

Chapter 18 - Mo Zhou's Gratitude

After standing there and pondering for a moment, Yuan decided that it would be better for him and Mo Zhou to just acknowledge being a disciple from the Blood Sect.

"That's right, I am indeed from the Blood Sect," he said with a confident voice.

"And I don't mind pretending what happened today did not occur, but you have to promise me that my friend, Mo Zhou, will no longer be bullied by his fellow disciples."

"Daoist Yuan!" Mo Zhou couldn't believe his ears and began crying. Why would Yuan go this far for him when he didn't do anything to really deserve this treatment?

"Mo Zhou, huh?" The Sect Leader turned to look at Mo Zhou for a moment before saying, "You will be my disciple starting today! Anyone who dares to touch you will have to answer me!"

"What?!"

When the Sect Leader made his announcement, everybody there gasped in shock, Mo Zhou included.

"Greet your new Master!" The Sect Leader continued.

Mo Zhou immediately kowtowed on the ground and bowed to him.

"This disciple greets Master!"

"Good! Starting today, you will be training under me!"

"Yes!"

Mo Zhou replied with enthusiasm in his voice.

Although Yuan did not expect such an outcome yet again, he was more than satisfied.

"Then I will be taking my leave," he said.

The Sect Leader nodded and looked at Mo Zhou again, "Go guide our guest to the exit!"

"Yes, Master!"

Thus, Mo Zhou brought Yuan and Xiao Hua away from the crowd.

Once they were gone, Sect Elder Jiang spoke, "Sect Leader... making Mo Zhou your disciple is a little bit..."

"Hmph!" The Sect Leader coldly snorted. "If you hadn't noticed by now, the sword technique used by that child is one of the Blood Sect's most powerful technique!"

"What?! Does this mean—"

"That child is definitely not just your average disciple from the Blood Sect. Judging from his prowess and ability to fight those many realms above himself, I won't be surprised if his Master is the Blood Sect's Master himself, Lord Blood!"

"Lord Blood!" Elder Jiang trembled in fear just by hearing his name.

"And if someone like him calls Mo Zhou his 'friend', then there's a high possibility that the Blood Sect will help us if we are ever in danger because of their relationship. If that's the case, then I won't hesitate to make him my disciple, even if it will make many disciples unhappy!"

Elder Jiang stared at him with a gaze filled with admiration. 'To think that the Sect Leader would be thinking so far ahead just to keep his Sect safe!

It's no wonder why he's the Sect Leader!'

"Sect Leader is sharp and wise, to think I doubted your decision even for a moment. Please, forgive me."

"If you want to be forgiven, then take care of the rest of this mess!" The Sect Leader said before walking away.

The news of Mo Zhou, a mere Outer Court disciple, suddenly becoming the Sect Leader's disciple came out of the blue and shocked every disciple within the Flying Swords Sect, especially those already at the top.

"What?! How could a nobody like Mo Zhou be chosen as the Sect Leader's disciple when the rest of us have been working our asses off just for that spot?!"

"The Heavens are unjust! This world is unfair!"

No doubt many people began to despise Mo Zhou because of his luck and bullshit, but alas, with the Sect Leader behind his back, who would dare to touch him now?

Outside the Flying Sword Sect, Mo Zhou dropped to his knees and kowtowed to Yuan, who was slightly taken back by his behavior.

"What are you doing?" Yuan tried to lift him off the floor.

"Daoist— No! Brother Yuan! Everything you have done for me, I do not know if I will ever be able to repay you but I will do my best as the Sect Leader's disciple and will one day return this debt!"

Yuan smiled and casually waved his hands, "Don't worry about it. Like I'd already said many times, I am not doing this because I want any reward."

"No! This is not a reward! I am doing this because I want to, just like you!" he quickly responded.

Yuan could tell that Mo Zhou will not change his mind no matter what he says at this point so he only shook his head inwardly and accepted the

outcome.

"Fine, do whatever you want."

"I will!"

"And good luck with that girl you fancy, I'm rooting for you."

"R-Right..." Mo Zhou began blushing.

"Then, I'll be leaving. I have already caused too much trouble in your place."

Yuan began walking away.

"Take care, Brother Yuan!" Mo Zhou waved at him from the Flying Sword Sect.

A few moments later, after Yuan left the Flying Sword Sect, messages appeared before his eyes:

«Congratulations! You have unlocked the Bond System!»

«'Mo Zhou' has been added to your Bond!»

«Mo Zhou's Bond level has increased to Acquaintance!»

«Mo Zhou's Bond level has increased to Friend!»

«Mo Zhou's Bond level has increased to Brotherhood!»

«Congratulations! Your Bond level with Mo Zhou has reached Brotherhood!»

«You have gained the following effect from Mo Zhou's Bond level: 'Mo Zhou's Gratitude'»

«Mo Zhou's Gratitude: Increases Sword Mastery by 25% and Sword Damage by 10%»

«Sword Mastery: Increases your control when wielding swords»

«Sword Damage: Increases your damage when wielding swords»

«Congratulations! You have unlocked Associations!»

«'Flying Sword Sect' has been added to your Associations!»

«Because of the drama you've caused there, your relationship with 'Flying Sword Sect' has decreased drastically!»

«Because of your bond level with 'Mo Zhou', Prime Disciple of 'Flying Sword Sect', your relationship with 'Flying Sword Sect' has increased greatly!»

«Congratulations! You have unlocked Fame!»

«Due to your actions at 'Flying Sword Sect', your Fame has increased by 10!»

«Fame: Increases as you make a name for yourself.»

Yuan nearly received a headache from the number of notifications being spammed.

"Where should we go now?" Yuan asked Xiao Hua as they left the area.

"Hmm..." Xiao Hua pondered as their figures entered the forest.

Chapter 19 - Spirit Warrior

As they traveled further away from the Flying Sword Sect, Xiao Hua thought to herself, 'It's only been a few days since Brother Yuan became a Cultivator, yet he is already powerful enough to hold his own against Spirit Warriors, even though he's only a Ninth Level Spirit Apprentice. This kind of growth is unheard of and is terrifying, to say the least. His experience with the sword is also increasing at a frightening rate, almost like he's the reincarnation of a Sword Emperor.'

"Besides wandering around aimlessly for valuable resources and collecting monster cores, there is really nothing else to do."

"Additionally, because Brother Yuan is already a Ninth Level Spirit Apprentice, he has to attain enlightenment before he can make a breakthrough and become a Spirit Warrior."

Xiao Hua turned to look at Yuan and spoke, "Brother Yuan, what would you like to do? Even if you keep consuming monster cores to fill your Qi, once you reach the peak of the Spirit Apprentice realm, you will not be able to gain more Qi unless you become a Spirit Warrior."

"How do I become a Spirit Warrior?" he asked her.

"To become a Spirit Warrior, you must comprehend the enlightenment that will come naturally once you reach the peak of the Spirit Apprentice realm. However, whether you will really gain enlightenment or not will depend on your fate and talent."

"What do you mean by that?"

Yuan expressed puzzlement.

"Although most people are born with the capability to cultivate, their max potential is predetermined before birth. For example, whilst Brother Yuan may be able to reach the peak of the Spirit Apprentice realm with ease, you might not gain enlightenment that is required to breakthrough to the Spirit Warrior realm, thus forever remaining a Spirit Apprentice."

"That being said, albeit valuable and hard to find, there are plenty of treasures out there that can help one exceed their limit and rewrite their fate."

Although she did not say it, Xiao Hua actually has a few of these treasures on her, so even if Yuan is destined to remain as a Spirit Apprentice forever, she can help him escape such a fate.

Yuan looked at his Qi Experience as he listened to Xiao Hua speak.

1,519,395/3,840,000

"If I consume 3 more monster cores, it should be more than enough to max out the Qi Experience..." Yuan thought to himself.

Suddenly, without thinking too much about it and excited to experience this enlightenment, Yuan retrieved three monster cores and threw them into his mouth all at once.

«Heaven Refining Physique activated»

«900,500 Qi has been refined from the Blood Ape's monster core»

«895,415 Qi has been refined from the Vampire Wolf's monster core»

«730,650 Qi has been refined from the Scaled Boar's monster core»

3,846,000/3,846,000

«You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough»

«Because your Qi Experience is already full, you will not be able to receive anymore Qi until you reach the next realm»

The notifications disappeared for a few seconds before returning.

«You have met the requirements for a breakthrough»

«You have reached First Level Spirit Warrior»

«Your 'Enhanced Senses' has developed into 'Advanced Senses'»

«You have learned Enhanced Strength»

«All stats +1,000»

—

«Advanced Senses»

«Rank: Mortal»

«Description: Sharply enhances the functions of all available senses permanently. Requires no activation»

—

«Enhanced Strength»

«Rank: N/A»

«Description: Greatly enhances your strength and stamina»

Once Yuan has reached the Spirit Warrior realm, he could feel a large amount of profound energy expanding in this body; it made him feel as though his body had increased in size despite having no changes made to his actual body.

"..."

Xiao Hua stared at Yuan with eyes as wide as two round eggs, her cute and round face filled with shock and disbelief.

"B-B-Brother Yuan... Y-Y-You..."

She couldn't believe what she'd just witnessed!

Although the Spirit Warrior realm is nothing special in her eyes and could be easily disregarded, Yuan had actually managed to become a Spirit Warrior without any enlightenment! Such an achievement was unprecedented even in the higher Heavens!

"B-Brother Yuan... what did you just do?" she asked him in a trembling voice.

"Hm? But I didn't do anything? Just like before, I had enough Qi for a breakthrough, and before I could even react, I had already become a Spirit Warrior."

Yuan responded, sounding somewhat disappointed that he did not get to experience this 'enlightenment'.

"Unbelievable..."

Xiao Hua still couldn't believe it. Just what kind of cultivating prodigy is Yuan? Hell, calling him a prodigy is still an understatement considering what he'd just accomplished!

While Xiao Hua was dumbfounded by his achievements, Yuan looked at his current stats.

Cultivation: First Level Spirit Warrior

Legacy: None

Bloodline: None

Physique: Heaven Refining Physique

Physical Strength: 3,734

Mental Strength: 3,975

Soul Strength: 4,910

Physical Defense: 3,710

Mental Defense: 4,821

Qi Experience: 3,846,000/38,460,000

"38 million?! I need 38 million Qi for the next level?! This is ridiculous!"

Yuan felt slightly dizzy after seeing the long numbers and sudden spike in the Qi required for the next level.

"I might as well eat the rest of the monster cores right now!"

Yuan retrieved all of his remaining monster cores and tossed it into his mouth.

However, what happened next dumbfounded him greatly.

«Heaven Refining Physique activated»

«Because you have consumed a monster core that is not suitable for your cultivation base, the overall absorbed Qi will be reduced by 90%»

«88,000 Qi has been refined from the Blood Ape's monster core»

«82,500 Qi has been refined from the Vampire Wolf's monster core»

«70,500 Qi has been refined from the Scaled Boar's monster core»

«85,000 Qi has been refined from the Vampire Wolf's monster core»

«65,000 Qi has been refined from the Hairy Serpent's monster core»

«66,700 Qi has been refined...»

«54,650 Qi has been refined...»

Qi Experience: 4,500,000/38,460,000

"W-W-What the hell?! Why am I barely getting any Qi from the monster cores now?!"

Xiao Hua's voice responded to his puzzlement a few moments later,
"Because Brother Yuan is now a Spirit Warrior, any monster core that is not from a Spirit Warrior beast will no longer be as effective."

"N-No way... but that makes no sense!"

"Brother Yuan's existence also makes no sense..." Xiao Hua sighed.

After calming down and thinking about it for a moment, Yuan realized that such a system was actually quite logical and fair, as it would prevent those with power that far exceeded this area's level range from taking advantage of the weak too much and force them to hunt stronger monsters.

"Well, this is a good time to take a break from cultivation, since I am starting to get tired of all this hunting... mentally..." he thought to himself.

"Xiao Hua, can you lead us to the nearest city? We can talk about our plans after we take a break."

Xiao Hua nodded and said, "The nearest city is 10 kilometers away."

"10 kilometers... let's run there."

Having never felt this energetic before, Yuan suggested running there.

"Okay." Xiao Hua easily agreed.

Thus, the two began running towards the nearest city.

Chapter 20 - Spirit City

After half an hour of running, Yuan and Xiao Hua could finally see the city walls.

«You have discovered 'Spirit City'»

"This place seems to be called Spirit City," said Yuan after reading the system notification.

"Spirit City is one of the four Great Cities within the Eastern Continent, and it's ranked third in terms of influence." Xiao Hua quickly explained.

"Then what are we waiting for? Let's go!"

Yuan and Xiao Hua approached the city gate.

"What are they doing?"

As they approached, Yuan noticed the crystal ball in one of the guards' grasp.

"It's to inspect the visitors. Unless Brother Yuan is a wanted criminal, you don't have to worry about it."

Yuan nodded.

A few minutes later, they reached the guards at the gates.

"Entrance fee is 1 silver for each individual," said the guard once they got close enough.

"Uh... Xiao Hua, do you have any money?" Yuan, who was penniless, looked at her with an awkward expression, feeling slightly embarrassed to be asking such a little girl for money.

But alas, Xiao Hua shook her little head.

"What the hell. Do you want to enter this place without money? Where did such beggars come from?" The guards sneered inwardly when they realized that they were dealing with penniless people.

"If you have no money, then I cannot allow you inside," said one of the guards. "Get out of the way already! There are people behind waiting for you!"

Yuan sighed and prepared to leave.

However, before he could even take a step, the person standing behind him spoke, "If you want, I can pay for your entrance fee."

Yuan turned to look at the person who just spoke; it was a pretty young lady wearing a pair of fine robes.

"If you don't mind..." Yuan spoke with an embarrassed face.

"Young Lady, we shouldn't bother ourselves with these two beggars..."

The old man standing beside the young lady suddenly mumbled into her ears, unaware that his words were heard by Yuan, who has enhanced senses.

"..."

However, Yuan decided to ignore the old man's disrespectful remarks.

"As the young lady of the Xuan Family, how could I ignore people in need of help? And it's just two silvers."

The young lady shook her head at the old man, looking disappointed by his words.

"Excuse me, this will account for their entrance fee, too."

The young lady then handed four pieces of silver coins to the guards.

After a quick glance, the guard nodded and retrieved the crystal ball.

"Place your hands on it," said the guard.

Yuan placed his hands on the globe.

A few seconds later, it glowed a green light.

"You may pass."

The guard then turned to Xiao Hua, who also passed with a green light.

A few moments later, once they have passed the inspection and entered the city, Yuan bowed to the pretty young lady.

"Thank you. Although it's not much, please accept this as my gratitude."

Yuan pulled out a Monster Core and placed it in front of the young lady, who immediately covered her mouth in surprise.

"B-Blood Ape Monster Core! This is simply too much for two mere silvers! I cannot accept this!" The young lady quickly refused.

Most Blood Apes are around the Eighth Level Spirit Apprentice Realm, and their monster cores would usually fetch at least 100 gold coins in the market place! If she accepted this monster core, it would make her feel guilty for taking advantage of Yuan.

"Don't worry, I have no more use for this quality of monster core, and it's only something I picked up during my travel here." Yuan understood the reason for the young lady's hesitation but continued to urge her to accept it.

The pretty young lady looked at Yuan's honest face and the shiny monster core in his hands and forcefully swallowed.

"Since you insist, I will accept it..." she accepted the Blood Ape Monster Core with trembling hands.

Once the monster core was off his hands, Yuan said to Xiao Hua, "Let's go."

"W-Wait! What's your name? I am called Xuan Wuhan!"

"You can call me Yuan," he responded.

"Thank you, Yuan! If you need help with anything, you can find my Xuan Family in Spring City!" Xuan Wuhan then handed Yuan a medallion made of metal and imprinted with the word 'Xuan'.

Yuan casually accepted the medallion without thinking too much about it.

«'Xuan Wuhan' has been added to your Bond!»

«Xuan Wuhan's Bond has increased to Acquaintance!»

"Then, I will see you around," he said before leaving with Xiao Hua.

After Yuan left, the old man beside Xuan Wuhan spoke, "Young Lady, why did you give him the family medallion? That is not something strangers should hold."

"That young man... despite his young age, there was a formidable aura around him. He's most likely a genius cultivator from some large family. If I can be friends with him, it will benefit our Xuan Family, not to mention his honest character. I like people like him."

"Are you sure about his background? He wasn't able to take out two silvers just now..." The old man remained doubtful.

"Were you even watching just now? He handed me a Blood Ape Monster Core worth over 100 gold coins without batting an eyelid because I gave him two silvers! That is not something even I would do! He must be testing people on purpose!"

"B-But why would he do something like that? What would he accomplish by testing others?"

Xuan Wuhan shook her head and spoke, "Just like my grandfather, the more profound and powerful the individual, the less sense they make. It is not something people like us can fathom."

"Are you saying that the young man just now is as powerful as the Ancestor, who is a Spirit Master? That's a bit..."

"Of course, not. I am just saying." Xuan Wuhan said. "Anyway, let's go. We cannot miss the auction, or we will have to deal with my father's angry shouting later."

Meanwhile, Yuan and Xiao Hua wandered around the city aimlessly.

"Xiao Hua, we need to earn some money. How about we sell the monster cores we hunted on our way here? They seem quite valuable," he said.

"Un. One monster core will easily sell for over 100 gold and will last us for a while, and we still have four of them."

"Then the question now is where to sell these monster cores..."

"If you want the most money out of the monster cores, we can look for an auction house. Although it might take some time, we will get the most profit out of it. If you do not mind selling them for much cheaper, any regular store that deals with monster cores will do the job," said Xiao Hua.

"An auction house, huh? That sounds kind of fun. I have never been to one before. But where can we find one?"

"Most big cities will hold an auction every few weeks, not to mention this Spirit City, one of the four biggest cities on this continent. We should find one with relative ease if we ask around."

Yuan nodded.

"If it won't take too long, I will use the auction house to sell my monster cores. But if we have to wait a few weeks, I'd rather just sell them for cheaper."

After deciding their next course of action, Yuan began asking around in hopes to find an auction house to sell his monster cores, as he did not want to experience today's humiliation any more in the future.

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Chapter 21 - Azure Phoenix Auction House

After walking around for half an hour and speaking to many people about the auction houses in this city, only one name came up repeatedly.

"This Azure Phoenix Auction House seems very popular. Let's give it a look," said Yuan.

Xiao Hua nodded and followed Yuan to the location of this Azure Phoenix Auction House.

According to the people Yuan spoke with, the Azure Phoenix Auction House is one of the wealthiest and most influential auction houses within the Eastern Continent. What's more, they are backed by the Azure Phoenix Sect, one of the most powerful backgrounds in this world.

"We are really fortunate to have arrived in this city right on the day it opens, right, Xiao Hua?"

"En." Xiao Hua nodded her little head.

The Azure Phoenix Auction House only opens once every three years because they have to stock up valuable treasures, and coincidentally, they came at the exact day it would open.

After walking around the Spirit City that occupies miles of land for many minutes, Yuan and Xiao Hua have finally arrived at the Azure Phoenix Auction House's entrance.

"Wow, this large place is the auction house?" Yuan couldn't help but become amazed by the luxurious building before him that took up an entire

street.

"Excuse me, is this the Azure Phoenix Auction House?" Yuan asked one of the people there just in case.

Once he confirmed that they were at the right place, Yuan approached one of two pretty young ladies standing silently by the entrance, assuming she was one of the workers here.

"Hello, do you work here?" he asked.

"I do," she replied with a gentle voice.

"Great! I came here today because I would like to sell something here."

"..."

The young lady looked at Yuan with a weird face after hearing his words.

"Umm... I'm sorry, but we stopped accepting things for the auction a month ago," she said a moment later.

"What...?"

Yuan stood there with a dumbfounded look.

The young lady chuckled and spoke, "Is this your first time at an auction house?"

"Yes..."

"Then let this sister teach you something about them. If you wish to sell something using auction houses, you must let them know ahead of time so they can put it on a list to let the guests know. People won't go to auction houses if they don't know what will be sold, you know? They have to prepare, too."

"I see... that makes sense..." Yuan sighed, feeling disappointed and slightly frustrated.

"Looks like I will have to sell these monster cores elsewhere..."

'Spirit Apprentice Realm monster cores?' The young lady noticed the monster cores in Yuan's hands and shook her head inwardly.

Even if Yuan was in time to sell his monster cores, the Azure Phoenix Auction House wouldn't accept something so insignificant. In fact, even if he brought Spirit Warrior Realm monster cores, the Azure Phoenix Auction House wouldn't even give it a glance.

The young lady did not want to disappoint Yuan anymore, who was clearly ignorant of many things, so she remained quiet.

However, the other worker there, who has been watching them since the beginning, burst out laughing, "Hahaha! Does this kid actually want to sell that trash at our Azure Phoenix Auction House?! This is hilarious!"

"Lian Rong! Why must everything that comes out of your mouth be so foul? He's clearly very young and ignorant! There's no need to mock him!"

The young lady beside Yuan frowned at her fellow worker's unsightly behavior.

"Hmph! I am only speaking the truth! And the earlier he learns, the faster he will grow up! Why are you even protecting a beggar like him, Na Ying?" Lian Rong coldly snorted, her gaze filled with mockery.

"Don't mind her, little brother. It's not a crime or disgraceful to be ignorant at times. " Na Ying tried soothing Yuan, acting like his next-door friendly sister.

"What's wrong with you, Na Ying? Are you perhaps charmed by this kid? Hahaha! I wonder how the disciples at Azure Phoenix Sect will react once they learn of this!" Lian Rong continued laughing.

"..."

Although Yuan did not mind Lian Rong's mockery, the little girl standing beside him was boiling with anger.

'This insignificant little ant has no idea who she's mocking! Brother Yuan is a genius among genius — a prodigy that will shock even the Upper Heavens! One day, Brother Yuan will become a figure that stands above all! I cannot allow him to continue being mocked!'

"Are you done embarrassing yourself yet? Even I am starting to feel ashamed just by being beside you!" Na Ying shook her head.

"You—! Are you looking for a fight, Na Ying?!"

"Oh? Do you want to fight me? Are you sure about that, senior apprentice-sister?" Na Ying narrowed her eyes, and the cultivation base of an expert at the peak Spirit Warrior Realm emitted from her body.

A bead of sweat appeared on Lian Rong's forehead after feeling Na Ying's pressure.

"J-Just you wait! Once we return to the sect, I will—"

"What's with the commotion here?!" A strong voice suddenly resounded.

A few seconds later, an old woman appeared in front of them with an annoyed face.

"Senior Chang!"

Both of the girls immediately stopped their argument and bowed to the old woman.

"Do not forget where the two of you are right now! Regardless of your status at the Azure Phoenix Sect, you are working for me now! And I will not tolerate this kind of behavior at my Azure Phoenix Auction House!"

"I am sorry..."

They quickly apologized.

"Enough. I will deal with you two afterward. The guests are already seated. Close the doors and come inside," said Senior Chang.

"Wait!"

Just as Senior Chang turned around, a cute but overbearing voice stopped her steps.

"X-Xiao Hua?" Yuan looked at her with wide eyes.

"What are you doing?" he whispered in her ears.

"Don't worry, Brother Yuan. Xiao Hua will deal with this," she responded with a smile on her face.

"Who the hell is this little girl?" Senior Chang frowned when she sensed a profound aura surrounding Xiao Hua's tiny body. It gave her a dreadful feeling.

"Are you the owner of this place?" Xiao Hua suddenly asked.

"That's right. And who are you?" Senior Chang responded.

However, Xiao Hua did not immediately respond and pulled out her storage pouch.

Then, right before their eyes, Xiao Hua pulled out a blue dagger from the pouch.

The instant the dagger was revealed to the world, an unfathomable presence suddenly appeared and enveloped the place.

"This presence—!!!" Senior Chang stumbled backward and nearly fell on her butt when she saw the dagger and sensed its aura.

"This dagger is a Heaven-grade weapon at the peak quality — Heavenly Frost Dagger," said Xiao Hua, and she continued in a calm manner, "Who I am is not important right now. What is important, though, is that I had planned to sell this dagger at your Azure Phoenix Auction House. However, because one of your workers mocked Brother Yuan and angered me, I am now having second thoughts."

After a moment of silence, Senior Chang's stiff body began trembling.

"Who?! Who dared to offend you?! I will kill that bastard for you!" Senior Chang's attitude took a sudden turn, shocking both Lian Rong and Na Ying, who has never seen her this agitated before, acting as though someone had just killed her son.

Even Yuan couldn't help but look at Xiao Hua with wide eyes. Since when did they come here to sell that dagger? And why does she feel so different right now?

"That girl over there!" Xiao Hua wasted no time pointing her small fingers.

Senior Chang turned to look at Lian Rong, who was as pale as a ghost right now, looking like all of her blood had just been drained out of her body.

"What have you done, Lian Rong?!" Senior Chang roared at her with a furious expression.

"I...I...I..."

Unable to respond and filled with despair, the young lady named Lian Rong fell to her knees, even pissing her pants due to fear.

Na Ying covered her mouth from shock as she witnessed this unexpected turn of events.

What's going to happen now?

Chapter 22 - VIP Room

"Senior Chang, this is what had happened..." Na Ying began explaining to her the events that took place right before she'd arrived.

"You... you foolish thing!" Senior Chang was speechless.

To think that Lian Rong, someone usually with keen eyes and great intelligence to misjudge a hidden expert due to her arrogance.

"There is nobody you can blame but yourself for being so arrogant and failing to recognize Mt. Tai!" she shook her head.

"Please! Senior Chang! You can't kill me! I am an Inner Disciple from the Azure Phoenix Sect!" Lian Rong began begging for her life.

"I am not the one who will decide whether you live or die today! You are begging the wrong person!"

After hearing Senior Chang's words, Lian Rong immediately ran to Yuan and kotowed before him, and she begged him with a face filled with tears and snot.

"Please, Young Master! This lowly one has failed to recognize someone as prestigious as you!"

"..."

Yuan was speechless. This is the first time he'd seen a young lady begging for him to spare her life.

"Young man, although she has wronged, I would also like to request for your forgiveness. After all, she is an Inner Disciple of the Azure Phoenix

Sect. If you kill her, they will surely..."

Yuan suddenly raised his hand and stopped her sentence.

"Wait a moment. I never said anything about killing her. You were the one who spoke such words. Do not try to act as though I was the one who wants her dead."

"I... I understand. Lian Rong! Be grateful! This young man has decided to spare your life!"

"Thank you, benefactor!" Lian Rong cried.

"..."

Yuan couldn't but help find these peoples' behavior weird and unnecessarily exaggerated. Why must she be executed for mocking him? If he was to kill anyone that has offended him, who knows how many people will die.

'I hope this won't become a trend amongst NPCs...' Yuan silently prayed.

"Ummm... now that everything has been settled... are you willing to sell your Heaven-grade dagger at our auction house? I promise you that you will not regret it! 80... no! You will receive 90% of the revenue, and we will only take 10%! Normally, it would be 75/25, but because we have troubled you today, I am willing to make it 90/10!" Senior Chang suddenly said.

In fact, Senior Chang did not care about the revenue of the Heavenly Frost Dagger. All that matters to her was the reputation that would come from selling it.

The last time a Heaven-grade weapon was sold at the Azure Phoenix Auction House was one hundred years ago, and it was only a low-quality weapon at that time! As for a Heaven-grade weapon at the peak quality — this would be the first one in their thousands of years of history!

Once the world learns of this, the Azure Phoenix Auction House will surely skyrocket in popularity, and they will receive much more attention and

guests in the future!

"You are asking the wrong person. I am not the owner of that weapon — she is." Yuan pointed to Xiao Hua, who was casually holding the dagger as though it was a normal weapon.

"En. I am willing to sell it but only under one condition." Xiao Hua said.
"You must also sell his monster cores at your place."

"Okay! I accept that condition!" Senior Chang immediately accepted without even needing to think about it.

Even if the Azure Phoenix Auction House loses a bit of face or becomes a laughing stock for selling Spirit Apprentice level monster cores, the Heaven-grade weapon will make up for it and more!

"Xiao Hua..." Yuan smiled warmly after realizing her intentions. To think that she'd be willing to sell such a precious item just for him, he couldn't thank her enough.

"Are you sure, Xiao Hua? That's a precious item, right? You don't have to force yourself to sell it. I can sell the monster cores elsewhere." Yuan said to her.

When Senior Chang heard Yuan's words, she felt the urge to beat him up and seal his mouth shut.

"It's only a Heaven-grade weapon, Xiao Hua has many more of them. And Brother Yuan does not use daggers, so it would only continue collecting dust." Xiao Hua said, dumbfounding Yuan.

'How can one have so many rare items but no money at the same time?' he wondered where she got all of these items from.

A few moments later, Xiao Hua handed the Heavenly Frost Dagger and the four Spirit Apprentice level monster cores from Yuan to Senior Chang.

"If you steal anything, I will destroy this place." Xiao Hua gave Senior Chang a stern warning before following Na Ying, who was assigned to

serve them, to one of the VIP rooms.

After they left, Senior Chang sighed a breath of relief.

"Even though she's a little girl, her attitude and presence are beyond normal, almost like that of an Immortal's! Not to mention that she actually dared to take out a peak quality Heaven-grade weapon out in the open! Even idiots would not dare steal from her..." Senior Chang felt the chills just thinking about her.

Just as Senior Chang began walking, she noticed that Lian Rong was sitting on the floor with a dazed face.

"Use this chance and change that arrogant attitude of yours. Even if you are an Inner Disciple of the powerful Azure Phoenix Sect, there are countless people in this world that you shouldn't offend."

"Yes, Senior..." Lian Rong nodded.

"Anyway, hurry up and return to work. I'm not paying you guys to stand around and be depressed all day," said Senior Chang before disappearing into the auction house.

Meanwhile, Yuan and Xiao Hua just stepped into the VIP room, where there were several other individuals.

"Kids?"

The people there turned their attention to Yuan and Xiao Hua, seemingly curious about their identity.

"Who are these kids? I don't recognize them."

"I don't know them, either."

"How could strangers enter this VIP room? They must have a shocking background that we are not aware of."

"I don't mean to brag, but I am familiar with every background that is capable of entering the VIP room, and even I don't know them."

It seemed as though nobody in the VIP room recognized Yuan, but that was to be expected, as he does not belong to any background and arrived in this world only recently.

"Yuan! I did not expect to see you so soon again!"

Suddenly, a pretty young lady approached him.

"You are... Xuan Wuhan?" Yuan also did not expect to see her here, especially when they were together not too long ago.

"If I knew that you were coming here, we could've come here together!" she said.

"Hahaha... I did not plan on coming here at first. It's only a coincidence."

"Coincidence or not, we are together again. Come here and sit at my table."

Yuan nodded and followed Xuan Wuhan to her table, where the old man from before and two unfamiliar handsome young men sat.

"The Young Lady was right... to enter this room, his background is not so simple after all." The old man was surprised to see Yuan in the VIP room.

"Who are they?" One of the young men asked after seeing Xuan Wuhan return with strangers.

"Friends I recently made," she said.

"Hmmm..."

The two handsome young men looked at Yuan with a pondering gaze.

"Which noble family are you from? I am Du Bai from the Du Family," said the handsome young man on the left.

"I am Du Hai, his twin brother," said the one on the right.

"Uh... I am not from any family," Yuan casually responded as he sat down beside Xuan Wuhan.

"What?"

They all looked at him with a surprised expression.

"Then you must be a disciple of a powerful sect. Which sect do you belong to?"

"I am also not a part of any sect. I'm a Rogue Cultivator," he said.

"..."

Once Yuan said those words, the entire room went silent, as everyone in the room was paying attention to him trying to figure out his identity.

"A... A Rogue Cultivator, you say? Hahaha... what a good joke..."

A few moments later, the entire room burst with laughter.

"There's no way some Rogue Cultivator would have the privilege to enter this VIP room!"

"Hahaha! He must really want to keep his background hidden!"

"Too bad that only makes me more intrigued!"

"..."

It was Yuan's turn to be speechless. He did not understand why they were laughing at him or why they couldn't believe his words. But regardless of the reason, since they don't believe him, there was nothing he could do. And it's not as though he cared whether they believed him or not.

"Just ignore them, Yuan." Xuan Wuhan said to him.

And just as she said those words, the lights in the room suddenly dimmed.

"The auction is finally starting," said Xuan Wuhan as she pointed to the large stage that was right below their VIP room.

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Chapter 23 - Beginning Of The Auction

"Hello, esteemed guests! Welcome to the Azure Phoenix Auction House! I will be your main host today, Qing Qing!"

A beautiful young lady appeared on the stage with a dazzling smile and a cheerful attitude, brightening the atmosphere despite the dimmed lights.

"Before we begin, allow me to remind you of the rules for this auction house! First of all, once you have made a bid on an item, it will be final and you cannot reclaim the offer! Rule number two, you are not allowed to pressure others with your background! This is an auction house, not the streets! After one warning, we will ask you to leave! And lastly, if you bid on an item and cannot afford it in the end, we will take whatever you have on hand until it's enough to pay the debt! If the debt is not paid, we will hold you until someone pays the debt!"

After announcing the rules, Qing Qing clapped her hands. A moment later, another beautiful lady appeared on the stage while pushing a cart covered by a thick cloth.

"Then without further ado, let me reveal the first item for today's auction — an Earth-grade medium quality chest plate made of silver metal, allowing it to have nearly no weight while retaining high defenses! As long as this armor is on your body, all damage dealt by those below the Spirit Master realm will be reduced in half!"

As Qing Qing announced the item, her assistant removed the cover on the cart and revealed the silver armor under it.

"50% damage reduction as long as their Cultivation is below the Spirit Master level? How powerful!" Yuan gazed at the armor with wide eyes. If he had such equipment, it would greatly increase his survivability in this world!

Xiao Hua noticed his desire for the armor in Yuan's eyes and spoke, "Brother Yuan, although it may sound powerful, it'll only work if your opponent is below the Spirit Master level. With your talent, you'll be fighting Spirit Masters in no time! What's more, with Xiao Hua here, nobody will be able to hurt you, even if they are a Spirit Grandmaster!"

Yuan chuckled at her confident face and nodded.

Meanwhile, the Du Brothers sitting on the other side of his table were glaring at the silver armor with drooling eyes.

"This is a must-have item! As long as we have this, we will be near-invincible within the Inner Court!"

They laughed loudly.

"Relying on treasures too much will affect your Cultivation, Du Bai, Du Hai." Xuan Wuhan reminded them after seeing their excited expressions.

However, as though they did not hear her, the Du Brothers continued to stare at the armor.

"The starting price for the armor will be 100,000 Gold!" Qing Qing announced.

"100,000 Gold!" Yuan could feel his heart skip a beat after hearing the price, and it was just the starting price. It's no wonder why they refused to accept his Monster Cores that would only sell for a measly 100 Gold.

"110,000 Gold!" The Du Brother immediately bid.

"115,000 Gold!"

"118,000 Gold!"

"120,000 Gold!

"130,000 Gold!"

The price went up by thousands with each call, and within minutes, it raised to 280,000 Gold!

"280,000 Gold... Even if there are players here, I doubt they'll have enough money to buy it..." Yuan thought to himself.

"280,000 Gold going once... going twice... and sold!"

"Yes! We got it!"

The Du Brothers hugged each other with joy after winning the bid.

"Their family must be filthy rich..." Yuan thought as he watched them celebrate.

"We will keep the item for now. After the auction ends, the winners may retrieve the item after paying the debt," said Qing Qing as she called for another assistant to go onto the stage.

"The next item will be a Spirit-grade Martial Technique, Fire Lotus Palm Strike! The ability packs devastating power and will also burn everything it touches! The starting price will be 10,000 Gold!"

"A single Spirit-grade skill costs over 10,000 Gold?!" Yuan was shocked.

Since all of his skills were either self-taught or taught by Xiao Hua, they were all free. He simply cannot imagine paying for an Earth-grade skill, much less a skill at the Divine-grade.

"Ummm... how much would a Divine-grade skill normally cost?" Yuan decided to ask Xuan Wuhan.

Xuan Wuhan looked at him with wide eyes. "Divine-grade? You cannot buy that kind of technique even with all of the money in this world! Hahaha!" she laughed afterward.

Yuan's jaw dropped to the ground after hearing her words. Cannot be bought with money? To think Xiao Hua would be so generous that she'd give out something like that for free! He suddenly felt the urge to wrap his arms around her and embrace her tightly!

A few minutes later, the Fire Lotus Palm Strike was bought by an old man in the VIP Room for 48,000 Gold.

"The third item is a Tier 3 pill, Soul Strengthening Pill with 80% purity, crafted by the renowned 3-Star Alchemist, Bai Ming!"

"Xiao Hua, what's an Alchemist? Do they turn things into gold?" Yuan asked her.

"Alchemists are medical experts that craft special medicine with their Cultivation, usually in the form of pills. Every pill has a different effect. Some can increase your strength while others can boost your stamina. Pills are usually expensive, so it's not an exaggeration to say they make gold..."

"I see..." Yuan nodded as though he understood something.

"Soul Strengthening Pill... it has a mind-calming effect, allowing you to achieve greater results during Cultivation. I want this!" Xuan Wuhan gripped her hands into a fist.

"Senior Bai personally crafted 15 Soul Strengthening Pill for today's auction, enough to fill three pill bottles, and we will be selling them separately. For the first bottle that contains 5 Soul Strengthening Pills, the starting price will be 5,000 Gold!"

Yuan's eyes nearly popped out of its sockets after hearing the price.

"Mother of fortune, 1,000 Gold for one tiny pill?! If I want to earn money quickly, it seems like becoming an Alchemist is the only way!" Yuan's interest in alchemy was piqued. He thought that if one day he has a chance to learn alchemy, he would definitely give it a try.

However, Xiao Hua also noticed this and quickly lowered his expectations of being an Alchemist by saying, "Although pills can be sold for good money, it's also incredibly hard to craft pills, and they usually end in failures unless you are a very skilled Alchemist. Even a single Tier 1 pill will require hours of effort to complete, not to mention that the supplies needed to craft the pill will also cost a lot of money. What's more, even geniuses will need to train for years before they can become a proper Alchemist. If Brother Yuan wants to become an Alchemist, you will need a lot of money, talent, and patience."

"..." Yuan's hype for Alchemists immediately dipped after hearing Xiao Hua's 'encouraging' words.

'Life is hard even inside a game, huh...' he sighed inwardly.

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Chapter 24 - Heaven

"6,000 Gold!" Xuan Wuhan immediately bid for the Soul Strengthening Pill once the auction began.

"6,100 Gold!"

"6,200 Gold!"

A few minutes later, Xuan Wuhan managed to secure the Soul Strengthening Pill for 7,500 Gold.

"Yes! Now I will be able to breakthrough to the third level Spirit Warrior Realm!" she made a victorious fist.

However, Xuan Wuhan was not satisfied with just a single bottle, so she proceeded to bid on the other two bottles.

After a few more minutes, two more bottles of Soul Strengthening Pills were handed to Xuan Wuhan, and she ended up paying 25,000 Gold for all three bottles.

"Hey, Yuan." Xuan Wuhan suddenly called for him.

"What's the matter?" he turned to look at her.

Xuan Wuhan smiled and opened one of the pill bottles to retrieve a Soul Strengthening Pill.

"Here you go. It's not much but I hope we can be friends for years to come!" she said while handing it to him.

Yuan accepted the pill with slightly widened eyes.

"Thank you!" he said with a smile on his face.

When Yuan held the Soul Strengthening Pill in his hands, the system automatically analyzed it for him.

[Soul Strengthening Pill] [Tier 3] [Purity: 82%]

[Effects: Permanently increases Soul Strength by 1,000]

[Description: A Spiritual Pill concocted by Bai Ming.]

[Limit: 3]

"It increases my Soul Strength permanently! And by 1,000!" Yuan exclaimed.

Xiao Hua then spoke, "Most pills have a limitation on how many you can consume before it no longer benefits your body. These Soul Strengthening Pills can only be eaten 3 times before it stops benefiting your body. With that being said, even if it won't improve your body, it still has other benefits such as calming your mind during Cultivation, hence why she bought so many of them."

"I see..." Yuan nodded.

"Hey, why don't you give us one of those pills too, Lady Xuan. Aren't we also friends?"

The Du Brothers asked her after seeing her give one to Yuan.

"If you wanted some, why didn't you even try to buy it?" Xuan Wuhan asked them.

"That's because you were very eager to have them, so we didn't fight for them with you," said Du Hai with a cheeky smile.

"Are you saying that I only won because you allowed me to win?" Xuan Wuhan narrowed her eyes at him.

Du Hai's cheeky smile quickly became an apologetic one and said, "T-That wasn't my intention..."

"Then forget it!"

"..."

After Xuan Wuhan turned her eyes away from him, Du Hai looked at Yuan with narrowed eyes, almost like he blamed Yuan for being responsible for the situation.

Sometime later, after ten more items were auctioned, Yuan's monster cores finally made its appearance.

"Umm... for our next item, we have a few monster cores..." Qing Qing sounded less confident and somewhat embarrassed by her own words.

"Monster Cores? Could it belong to a Beast that was at the Spirit Master level?" The people were slightly surprised by the appearance of monster cores, as they are rarely sold in Auction Houses.

"They are Spirit Apprentice level monster cores," said Qing Qing with a weird tone.

"Spirit Apprentice monster cores? Did the Auction House mess up? How could they sell such trash here?"

"There must've been a mistake. I cannot imagine the Azure Phoenix Auction House purposefully selling trash."

"The Azure Phoenix Auction House does not make mistakes. Although I don't know the reason, these monster cores were approved by Senior Chang herself," said Qing Qing, and she continued, "The starting price for all four of these monster cores will be 500 Spirit Stones."

However, nobody made a bid even after many minutes. It was an unprecedented event for the Azure Phoenix Auction House.

"Just take those trash away from our sights! Are you mocking us with them? Nobody wants it!" Du Bai shouted loudly.

"That's right! What kind of joke is this? Even if you are the Azure Phoenix Auction House, there is a limit."

Following Du Bai, other guests also began complaining. To sell something worth so little in this high-end Auction House with treasures worth tens of thousands of Gold was akin to selling street meat in a luxurious restaurant. The guests were feeling as though they were being mocked by the auction house.

"What should I do...? Senior Chang told me to sell these even if we have to lose face!" Qing Qing cried inwardly.

Meanwhile, in the VIP Room, Yuan was slightly trembling from anger. Even though the complaints were directed at the auction house and Qing Qing, he felt as though they were all directed at him, who wanted to sell these monster cores.

Xuan Wuhan noticed the irritated expression on Yuan's face and wondered if the monster cores belonged to him. After all, he gave her one of them at the city's entrance.

"It's just a few hundred golds. If these monster cores really belong to him, it'll definitely benefit our relationship, and he might even owe me for giving him face. It might also be another one of his tests..."

Thus, Xuan Wuhan spoke the next moment, "I will bid 600 Gold for these monster cores."

"Lady Xuan! Why would you bid for the monster cores? They are just trash! Don't waste your money on them. If you want, I can give you some at the Spirit Warrior level for free as a gift!" Du Hai said to her.

"Shut up! Do I need your permission if I want to buy something? I just happened to need these monster cores, so I am buying them!" she coldly snorted.

"..." Yuan looked at her with wide eyes.

'Not only did she give me a Soul Strengthening Pill worth hundreds of Gold but she's also buying my monster cores... I will definitely thank her properly in the future...' he thought to himself with a warm smile on his face.

"Would you like to pay for the monster cores now?"

An assistant from the auction house asked Xuan Wuhan after she easily won the bid due to a lack of competitors.

Xuan Wuhan retrieved 600 Gold and handed it to the assistant. "I want it now," she said.

"Understood."

The assistant accepted the money and returned a few minutes later with the monster cores.

Meanwhile, on the stage, a new item was already being auctioned.

"For the next item, we have this piece of crystal that is of unknown origin. Although we cannot tell you the purpose of its existence, it has a large amount of Qi flowing within like a monster core. In fact, if it was a monster core, it would be comparable to one at the Spirit Grandmaster level." Qing Qing showed them the cobble-sized piece of crystal to the guests.

"Comparable to a Spirit Grandmaster monster core!"

The people were shocked, as monsters at the Spirit Grandmaster level were exceedingly rare and terrifying, and they have the power to wipe out a large city like this Spirit City with ease. In fact, the last time a Spirit Grandmaster monster appeared in this world was 1,000 years ago, killing millions of people and nearly destroying the world if not for the Spirit Grandmasters that sacrificed their own lives to kill it.

When Xiao Hua saw the cobble-sized crystal, her eyes slightly widened.

"Brother Yuan, that's a Spirit Crystal."

Xiao Hua's voice suddenly resounded in his head.

"Spirit Crystal? Like the Ancient Spirit Jade I have?" he asked.

"No, it's not real Spirit Jade. Real Spirit Jade, even at the lowest quality, would have more Qi. And even though it's not comparable to Spirit Jade, it'll still provide a big boost to your Cultivation. It can also be used as a currency in the upper Realms."

'I wonder how much Qi I would get from consuming it,' he pondered.

"Brother Yuan, you should bid for it." Xiao Hua suddenly said.

"What? But I don't have any money."

"We may have no money now but we will have plenty once we sell the Heavenly Frost Dagger. It'll be more than enough to buy something like this Spirit Crystal, and the people here seem to be unaware of its true value."

Yuan pondered for a moment and asked, "Are you sure? It's still your money."

Even if Xiao Hua allowed him to use the money from selling the Heavenly Frost Dagger, Yuan was not shameless enough to accept it. In fact, if he accepts it despite everything that she's already given him, it'll make him feel guilty instead.

"Buy it, Brother Yuan." Xiao Hua nodded with a resolute face.

"Okay, if you say so."

"I must get this piece of crystal that is overflowing with Qi! If I can cultivate the Qi inside, I might even breakthrough and become a Spirit Master in no time!"

Xuan Wuhan's eyes glittered with excitement.

"There's no way something that contains so much Qi is not a treasure! It must be a treasure with a powerful ability!"

Not just Xuan Wuhan but Du Brothers and the others in the VIP room were also trembling in excitement.

"Since we do not know its true value, we will let the guests decide. The auction begins now!" Qing Qing announced loudly.

"10,000 Gold!"

"30,000 Gold!"

"100,000 Gold!"

The people immediately began bidding, and the price fluctuated quickly.

Within mere minutes, the price for the Spirit Crystal reached half a million Gold.

"Xiao Hua... it's already at 500,000 Gold. Are we still going to buy it?" Yuan asked her.

Xiao Hua did not hesitate for a second and nodded.

"500,100 Gold!" Yuan made a bid for the first time in this auction and in his life.

"This brat... he's not a simple one, as expected..."

The people in the VIP room glanced at Yuan with the corner of their eyes.

'You want to buy something when I am here? Then you will have to ask me for permission first!' Du Hai coldly sneered in his heart and raised his hand.

"510,000 Gold!"

"510,100 Gold." Yuan calmly responded.

Du Hai gnashed his teeth and spoke loudly, "Are you purposely trying to provoke me by adding so little every time?!"

Yuan raised an eyebrow at Du Hai's words, as he truly didn't understand why Du Hai would be upset about that. "Is there something wrong with that?"

"..."

Du Hai trembled in anger at Yuan's response, thinking that he was being mocked.

"520,000 Gold! This is how you bid in an auction! What is the point in adding so little?!"

"520,100 Gold. What if I add too much and waste money? I'd rather play it safe." Yuan innocently shook his head.

After all, it was not his money that he's using to bid.

Xuan Wuhan chuckled after hearing Yuan's words, which only fueled Du Hai's rage even further.

"Good! Since you want to play that game, then I will also play!"

"520,200 Gold!"

"520,300 Gold."

"520,400 Gold!"

"520,500 Gold."

After a few minutes of bidding back and forth, Du Hai was finally unable to endure it and burst with anger, "You mother fucker! How dare you play with me like this!"

Seeing Du Hai lose control of his temper and preparing to strike Yuan, Na Ning, who had been standing in the background in silence stood forward

and spoke, "Esteemed guest, please behave yourself. If you continue any further, we will have to ask you to leave."

"Du Hai, sit back down!" Du Bai grabbed Du Hai's robes with a frown.

"Che!" Du Hai coldly snorted and returned to his seat. However, his narrowed gaze remained on Yuan even after many moments later.

"We cannot afford to offend the Azure Phoenix Sect! And give up on this treasure. Our money won't last till the end if you spend so much at once. If you want to deal with him, we can do it after the auction." Du Bai whispered in Du Hai's ears afterward.

"Yuan, the Du Brothers are unforgiving people. They will surely try to cause trouble for you afterward. I will speak to them later." Xuan Wuhan whispered in Yuan's ears when she noticed their suspicious gazes.

"Thank you for the warning. " Yuan nodded.

Although he was not afraid of them, he'd rather not have to deal with them.

A few minutes later, Yuan won the bid with 550,000 Gold.

"Esteemed guest, would you like to pay for the item now, or would you like to pay for it afterward?" Na Ning asked him with a polite tone and a respectful demeanor.

"You can subtract it from that item afterward." Xiao Hua said to her.

"I understand." Na Ning nodded and walked away.

Xuan Wuhan raised her eyebrows at Xiao Hua words, and she pondered. 'That item? Did they put something else besides the monster cores up for auction?'

After selling the Spirit Crystal, a few more items were sold.

"Before we start the auction for the final item we have today, allow me to introduce the owner of this auction house, Senior Chang!" Qing Qing

suddenly said, dumbfounding the people there.

"Madam Chang will be making an appearance today? How rare."

The people thought.

A few moments later, an old lady appeared on the stage with a wooden box in her hands.

"Thank you all for coming to my auction house today. Since the last item we have for today is a little bit special, I will be conducting the final auction." Senior Chang spoke in a low voice, yet her voice echoed in every corner of the room.

After saying those words, Senior Chang opened the wooden box and revealed the beautiful dagger resting inside.

"T-That aura! It's a Heaven-grade treasure!"

Without even needing Senior Chang to introduce the Heavenly Frost Dagger, the people there were already able to tell what kind of treasure it was from the profound aura that was shrouding the blue dagger.

"It's really a Heaven-grade treasure! Hahaha! I have lucked out by coming here today!"

"Even though I won't be able to afford it, I am already satisfied to witness something so valuable with my own eyes!"

The crowd went into an uproar after the appearance of the Heavenly Frost Dagger, as the last time something this precious appeared in the public was 100 years ago!

Chapter 25 - End Of The Auction

"Elder Jia, we must buy this Heaven-grade treasure at all cost!" Xuan Wuhuan said to the old man beside her with a serious expression.

"I agree with the Young Lady. Although it might get expensive very fast, Heaven-grade treasures do not appear very often in this world, and this one appears to be of great quality, too."

"Du Hai, this treasure..."

"Of course, we are going to try and bid for it! Even though we might not win, we cannot simply sit here and do nothing while there is such a treasure before us!" Du Hai spoke with a regrettable face.

Although the Du Family has decent wealth, compared to the other esteemed guests in the V.I.P room, their wealth is nothing significant. However, even if there's the slightest chance they could buy the Heaven-grade treasure, they will surely try.

The V.I.P room quickly became chaotic, and everybody there looked at the Heavenly Frost Dagger with lustful eyes.

Even if they have to use all of their money and replace the food on their dinner table with water for the next ten years, they felt that it would all be worth it if they obtained the treasure.

Once the anticipation within the auction house was at its maximum, Madam Chang spread her arms and spoke with a wide smile, "Then without further ado, let the bidding for this peak quality Heavenly Frost Dagger begin at 10 million gold!"

Despite the outrageous price, the people at the auction house began bidding like animals.

"11 million gold!"

"11.5 million gold!"

"13 million gold!"

Within minutes, the minimum price for the Heavenly Frost Dagger increased to 21 million gold.

"21 million gold..." Yuan listened to the biddings with a dazed face, seemingly in disbelief.

He cannot even begin to imagine what he could do with that much wealth.

"25 million gold!" Xuan Wuhuan suddenly shouted.

The sudden high bid by Xuan Wuhuan slowed the bidding pace briefly, but after a few moments, it returned to normal.

When the bidding reached 30 million gold, the pace finally slowed down permanently, as only very few individuals there could afford to bring out so much money.

"30.5 million!"

Of course, Xuan Wuhan, whose family belonged to the business circle, was one of these rich individuals.

"31 million!"

"31.5 million!"

After a few more minutes of bidding from the same three people, a new voice suddenly resounded.

"40 million gold."

The voice was profoundly calm, causing everybody in the V.I.P room to turn to look at the person who just spoke.

However, that person had not been in the V.I.P room since the beginning, and the people there wondered when this person arrived.

"T-That's Qi Jiguang from Heaven and Earth Palace! What's he doing in this place?!" Someone there exclaimed after realizing his identity.

"What?! The Heaven and Earth Palace?!" Although most people there were unfamiliar with the name Qi Jiguang, they all gasped in shock after hearing the name 'Heaven and Earth Palace'.

"That man is at the peak of the Spirit Grandmaster. He's considered as a peak expert in the Lower Heavens." Xiao Hua mumbled to Yuan, who seemed to be dazed by the profound aura surrounding this Qi Jiguang.

"I wonder what it would be like to fight someone as powerful as him..." Yuan said in a low voice.

Xiao Hua looked at him with raised eyebrows. "As expected of a battle junkie. In this entire room, you are probably the only one thinking such a thing, Brother Yuan. But at your current cultivation, you won't even last a second against a single finger from him. You'll die instantly."

"Hmm?"

When Qi Jiguang noticed the two of them looking at him, he also looked back.

Although there was nothing out of the ordinary about Yuan, he could sense an invisible yet formidable aura coming from Xiao Hua.

'That little girl... I cannot see her cultivation base, but she's without a doubt an expert like me.' Qi Jiguang thought to himself.

While her presence piqued his interest, he did not want to involve himself with another expert at his level without any good reason, as that might lead to unnecessary confrontation.

Many moments have passed since Qi Jiguang bid 40 million gold for the Heavenly Frost Dagger without anyone else trying to outbid him.

'Damn it! Why did someone like him have to appear here today?!' Xuan Wuhuan cried inwardly. While she had the ability to continue bidding, she did not want to fight against someone from the Heaven and Earth Palace and accidentally offend him, as that would be devastating for her family and its business.

"Since there doesn't seem to be any more bidders, the bid for this Heaven-grade treasure shall come to an end! Congratulations to the esteemed guest for winning this exquisite treasure!" Madam Chang clapped with smiles all over her face, as she just earned 4 million gold from this transaction alone.

After the auction ended, Xuan Wuhan said to Yuan, "If you ever need anything, come find me at Spring City. You can show anyone the medallion I gave you, and they will lead you to me. I hope to see you again later, Yuan."

The Du Brothers glanced at Yuan with narrowed eyes for a moment before leaving the place.

Sometime later, Na Ying approached them after the auction ended and said, "Esteemed Guests, please follow me to claim your sales."

Yuan nodded and proceeded to follow her to a private room at the top of the auction house.

"Madam Chang will be here in a few moments with your earnings, please relax in the meantime." Na Ying said to them as she poured them a cup of spiritual tea.

«You have gained the following effect from consuming Phoenix Blossom Tea»

«Increased Qi Absorption Rate by 10% for 12 hours»

«Soul Strength +500 permanently»

Yuan gained some stats after drinking the tea.

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Chapter 26 - Wealth Leaderboards

"What wonderful tea..." Yuan mumbled after sipping the tea, feeling a little bit stronger after just a single sip.

"I'm glad you like this tea, Esteemed Guest. It's called the Phoenix Blossom Tea, a spiritual tea made by the Azure Phoenix Sect. Usually, only Elders within the Sect are allowed to enjoy this tea, but Madam Chang specifically wanted you to try it." Na Ying said to him with a smile.

A few minutes later, Madam Chang entered the room and bowed to them.

"Thank you for being patient with this one, Esteemed Guests. I have just finished organizing your sales."

She then placed a ring made of jade and a small red pouch on the table before them and continued, "I have already deducted the auction house's 10% share and your purchase worth 550,000 gold from the income, so there are 35 million gold and your purchase in the Spatial Ring from the Heaven-grade treasure and 540 gold in the Storage Pouch from the monster cores."

"And you can keep the Spatial Ring and the Storage Pouch as well. Although it's nothing significant when compared to the Heaven-grade treasure, please consider it as a small gift from the Azure Phoenix Sect."

«Spatial Ring»

«Grade: Earth»

«Mental Strength Required: 5,000»

«Description: A mythical ring that contains its own space, allowing you to store things inside and retrieve them with a thought.»

«Storage Pouch»

«Grade: Spirit»

«Mental Strength Required: 500»

«Description: A pouch that contains its own space. Although there's not much room inside, you can fit a few watermelons inside.»

Yuan picked up the jade ring and the red pouch, and a notification appeared before him.

«35,450,560 gold has been received»

«You have unlocked the Wealth Leaderboards»

«Congratulations! You have reached first place in 'Wealth Leaderboards', becoming the wealthiest player in Cultivation Online»

«Congratulations! You have obtained the unique title 'Rich Young Master'!»

«Fame +100»

When Yuan saw that he'd become the richest player in Cultivation Online, he didn't express any surprise. In fact, it would be more surprising if he wasn't in the first place!

"Xiao Hua, here, take this."

After receiving the Spatial Ring, he handed it to Xiao Hua, who looked at him with a puzzled face.

"Why are you giving it to me, Brother Yuan? It's your money."

However, Yuan shook his head and said, "To begin with, it was your treasure that was sold, and I will feel bad for accepting this much money when it doesn't even belong to me."

"Xiao Hua belongs to Brother Yuan. Everything in Xiao Hua's possession is also Brother Yuan's possession, so it's not weird."

"I know, but it still doesn't feel right with me, getting so much wealth when I didn't do anything to deserve it. Keep it. But when we really need that money, we can use it." Yuan was adamant about not accepting the 35 million gold.

He felt that it was too much money for him at his current level and that it would take away all of the fun in the game if he could buy whatever he wanted with such ease.

In fact, he even feels slightly guilty for having an overpowered companion such as Xiao Hua by his side.

However, obtaining a massive amount of resources without working for it and earning these resources by himself are two entirely different matters. Furthermore, as someone who could only rely on others to help him survive for almost his entire life, he did not want to rely too much on Xiao Hua, who resembled his real younger sister, hence why he refused the gold.

Seeing the stubbornness in Yuan's eyes, Xiao Hua ultimately nodded her head and accepted the Spatial Ring and all of the money inside.

However, after taking the Spatial Ring, she transferred the money inside the Spatial Ring to her own Storage Pouch, before handing the Spatial Ring back to Yuan.

"Brother Yuan, I will take the money, but you should keep the Spatial Ring. It'll be very convenient for you since you can carry many things with you without the burden of carrying its weight that way."

Yuan nodded and accepted the Spatial Ring without much thought, completely oblivious to the fact that the Spatial Ring itself was valued at a few hundred thousand golds.

Meanwhile, outside of the Azure Phoenix Action House, a large notification was hanging above the clouds with countless eyes staring at it.

«Player Yuan has become to first Player to unlock the Wealth Leaderboards by accumulating over 1,000,000 gold»

"Somebody has already earned over one million gold?! How is that even possible?!"

"Look! It's that alleged cheater, Yuan!"

"Holy shit! If you convert that amount of gold into real-life money, that's over ten million dollars at the market's current rates!"

Since Cultivation Online is a video game — a very popular one at that — there would obviously be people using the game to make profits in real life by trading in-game currencies for real-life currencies, and at the current state of the game, a single gold coin was worth around ten dollars in real life.

This type of business is usually called Real World Trading, RWT for short, and is against the terms of service for most online games out there. However, despite being against the terms of services, there are many people who would rather go out of their way to use such services to strengthen themselves in-game than to waste time and effort to earn them fairly.

Furthermore, this type of business is not limited to only in-game gold, as people buy in-game treasures and resources with real money, too.

With all that being said, RWT is not against Cultivation Online's terms of services, as such terms never existed in the first place, so there are already many players using their real-life money to buy Cultivation Online gold and vice-versa.

If Yuan were to convert all of his in-game gold to real-life currency, he'd have over 350 million dollars right now. But of course, Yuan is oblivious to such a business market, thus such thoughts never crossed his mind.

"If you ever need to sell anything to our Azure Phoenix Auction House, please come by again."

Madam Chang handed them a badge with the auction house's name on it.

«You have obtained Azure Phoenix Auction House Diamond Pass»

"As long as you have that pass, you can enter any auction house in this world that is owned by the Azure Phoenix Sect."

"Thank you."

After accepting the pass, Yuan and Xiao Hua left the auction house.

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Chapter 27 - Stuffing His Face With Food

Once Yuan and Xiao Hua left the auction house, they wandered around the city aimlessly.

"What should we do now, Xiao Hua? Now that we have enough money, maybe we should better gear ourselves for the future."

However, Xiao Hua merely tilted her head in a puzzled manner and spoke, "But Xiao Hua has plenty of treasures you can use."

Yuan showed a bittersweet smile and said, "While that is true, I cannot rely on you for everything. I want to work hard and earn my own equipment, too."

Xiao Hua remained puzzled, and she asked, "Xiao Hua has noticed this for a bit now, but why does Brother Yuan want to work so hard? If it were someone else in your shoes, they would surely take advantage of the situation and not do so much work."

Yuan chuckled after hearing her words and said, "Although it may not seem like it, I have lived the majority of my life as a cripple, where I cannot even use the bathroom without help from someone else. I hate the feeling of being so powerless and useless, and despite breathing, I never felt alive. But now that I can finally use my useless body again, I want to enjoy life to the fullest and experience what it means to be alive."

"Brother Yuan... you must have lived a difficult life..."

"Past tense?" Yuan laughed in a dispirited tone, "Even though I may appear fine now, I am actually still living that pointless life."

"..."

"But Brother Yuan is no longer a cripple! He's even a cultivation genius!" Although Xiao Hua does not know his situation, she could feel a sense of loneliness and desperation within his tone.

"That may be true in this world, but once I log out, I will return to being a cripple in that dark and still world. Anyway, let's leave this depressing topic behind and enjoy ourselves with our newfound wealth." Yuan said as he continued walking around the city.

Meanwhile, Xiao Hua silently stared at him with a pondering gaze, seemingly in deep thoughts.

'Maybe there's something Xiao Hua can do to relieve Brother Yuan's pain...' she thought to herself.

Sometime later, they arrived at what appears to be an equipment shop.

"Welcome to the Dragon Armory!" The middle-aged man behind the counter said to them after noticing their presence. "We have all sorts of Spirit-grade weapons and armor! If you are looking for something specific, just let me know!"

"I will," Yuan said as he began looking around.

«Bone Sword»

«Grade: Spirit»

«Quality: Medium»

«Physical Strength Required: 300»

«Mental Strength Required: 600»

«Sharpness: 300»

«Description: A sword made from the bones from a Spiritual Skeleton»

«Price: 30,000 Gold»

«Fiery Lizard Scale Armor»

«Grade: Spirit»

«Quality: High»

«Physical Strength Required: 500»

«Mental Strength Required: 250»

«Physical Defense: 5,000»

«Description: Crafted with highly durable scales from a Fiery Lizard»

«Price: 80,000 Gold»

'Good lord, the equipment here is so expensive!' Yuan's eyes widened when he saw the price for these Spirit-grade weapons. It made the 540 Gold he'd earned completely insignificant!

"It's expensive, right?" Xiao Hua could read his expression and said with a smile. "Unless you are from a noble family or have the backing of a powerful Sect, nobody would come to these places to look for equipment."

"Why didn't you tell me before we walked in here? Now I feel like a beggar walking into a jewelry store..." Yuan sighed. "Let's leave and get something to eat instead."

When the middle-aged man saw that they were leaving after looking at just two items, he sucked his teeth in disdain, "Che! To think I'd wasted my breath greeting these poor bastards."

"..."

Hearing such words, Yuan stopped walking and turned around to look at the middle-aged man with a frown.

"What? Are you going to hit me for speaking the truth?" The middle-aged man remained nonchalant and even continued to insult him. "This store is owned by the Earth Dragon Sect. Hit me if you dare."

"..."

Yuan's eyebrows twitched at the irritating tone coming from the middle-aged man, but he had nothing to say, as he was truly poor. Furthermore, he didn't want to cause unnecessary trouble inside a shop owned by an NPC because who knows what the NPC might do.

However, Xiao Hua was not as kind as Yuan, and she despised people looking down on Yuan, her beloved Master. A moment later, she retrieved her storage ring and pulled out two peak quality Heaven-grade treasure—one in each of her small hands.

When the middle-aged man realized that she was holding two Heaven-grade weapons and was even treating them as though they are mere toys, his eyes rolled back from shock, and he collapsed the next moment.

'That's what you get for bullying Brother Yuan.' Xiao Hua sneered inwardly before putting away the Heaven-grade weapons and leaving the store with a satisfied expression on her cute face.

Once they left the store, Yuan and Xiao Hua went to a nearby restaurant, where they proceeded to fill their stomach with delicious food.

'Oh my god! This food is crazy delicious! I can't believe how real it tastes inside a game!' As though he'd turned into a starving beast, Yuan stuffed food into his mouth and down his throat, and both of his hands were occupied with food at all times.

Meanwhile, Xiao Hua watched him eat like an animal with her jaw hanging. This is the first time she has seen anyone eating so frantically. It was almost as though he'd never eaten anything before today.

"The food isn't going anywhere, Brother Yuan. If you don't eat slowly, you might choke to death," she said to him.

"I can't help it! My hands are moving by themselves! After all, I have eaten nothing but soup for the last few years!" Yuan said in a stuffed voice as he continued to mercilessly shove food into his mouth with tears flowing down his fat cheeks.

Xiao Hua merely shook her head before she began to eat her own plate of food with elegance.

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Chapter 28 - Cooking Techniques

After spending nearly three hours stuffing his face with food in the restaurant, Yuan was finally satisfied with his stomach, which was fully bloated at this moment, making him appear fatter than normal.

"Unbelievable... Brother Yuan's stomach is a true mystery. Not only can you consume monster cores and feel perfectly fine, but you can also eat enough food to feed ten whole families..." Xiao Hua stared at him with wide eyes.

"Hahaha... I don't usually eat so much, but for some season, when I swallow the food, it feels as though the food disappears before it even reaches my stomach." Yuan said. "And my Qi has increased significantly, too."

After consuming so much food, his Qi Experience has increased by 1 million, comparable to the Jade Frog's monster core.

"That's because of the food Brother Yuan ate. It's not ordinary food, but spiritual food, which is cooked from monsters and contains spiritual energy."

"Is that why it also tasted so good? Man, I should eat more of these so-called spiritual foods." Yuan said as he rubbed his stomach.

However, when the bill appeared sometime later, Yuan immediately regretted eating so much.

"500 gold coins?! That's nearly everything I have! Why the hell is it this expensive?! Did they miscalculate the bill?" Yuan exclaimed with a terrified expression.

"Brother Yuan... did you order the food without looking at the prices? Spiritual food is considered luxury food... of course it would be expensive... and you ate so much of it..." Xiao Hua said to him.

Yuan sighed and spoke, "If it's like this, I'd rather hunt and cook my own food."

"That's an option, too." Xiao Hua nodded. "After all, it's just cooked monster meat."

"Then it's decided! In order to save money, I shall learn how to cook spiritual food!"

And he continued, "By the way, are there any techniques that teach you how to cook?"

Xiao Hua nodded and said, "It'll cost you a few gold coins, but you can find these kinds of techniques in any Cultivator market."

"Great. Then let's go shopping again after this."

After paying the massive restaurant bill that depleted almost everything he's earned from selling the monster cores, Yuan and Xiao Hua returned to strolling in the streets.

Sometime later, they approached a store with a large sign that read 'Cultivator Essentials'.

"Welcome to Cultivator Essentials! How may I assist you, Young Master?" A pretty lady greeted him with a warm smile after noticing their presence.

"Hello. Do you sell cooking techniques in this place?" Yuan asked her.

"Cooking techniques, huh? Give me a moment to check."

The pretty lady then went to the back of the shop.

A few minutes later, she returned with three books in her hand.

"We have three cooking techniques. Pick whichever is to your liking."

"Hmm..." Yuan looked at the three techniques before him.

"Thousand Knife Techniques... Heavenly Fire Control... Senior Wu's Recipes..."

Yuan made a weird expression after reading the title of these three books.

"Are they really cooking techniques? They look more like fighting techniques... And the last one... it's only a recipe book, right?"

The pretty lady behind the counter chuckled, and she said, "I can assure you that they are cooking techniques. If you aren't convinced, I can let you read a few pages for yourself."

"Really? Then excuse me..."

Yuan picked up the techniques and began reading them one at a time.

A few minutes later, a notification appeared.

«You have learned Thousand Knife Technique»

«Thousand Knife Technique»

«Rank: Mortal»

«Mastery Level: 1»

«Description: Consumes 100 Qi. Must wield a knife or dagger to activate. A common knife technique for chefs around the world.»

«You have learned Heavenly Fire Control»

«Heavenly Fire Control»

«Rank: Mortal»

«Mastery Level: 1»

«Description: Consumes 10 Qi per second. Allows you to control and adjust temperatures of regular fire with your spiritual energy.»

«You have read Senior Wu's Recipes»

«Your Cooking knowledge has increased significantly»

«You have learned Cooking Skill»

«Cooking Skill»

«Mastery Level: 1»

«You have learned new cooking recipes»

«You can now cook Tier 1 spiritual food»

"Uh..." Yuan did not mean to learn the techniques without paying, and he turned to look at the pretty lady with a worried face, but she appeared to be oblivious of what just happened.

"How much are these techniques, again?" he asked her with a shaky voice.

"Ten gold coins each!" she quickly responded with a bright smile.

"..."

Not wanting to feel like he'd just committed a robbery, Yuan decided to pay for these techniques even if it will cost him all of his remaining money.

"I will buy them..." He said in a sighing voice, before taking out 30 gold coins and placing it on the counter.

"Thank you very much for your purchase, Young Master!" The pretty lady immediately accepted his money with her face full of smiles.

After buying the three cooking techniques, Yuan and Xiao Hua left the shop.

"Haaa... I only have 10 gold coins left..." Yuan sighed deeply after taking a look into his empty wallet.

"Should Xiao Hua give you some money? After all, she made Brother Yuan pay for her own share of food in the restaurant." Xiao Hua said to him after seeing his saddened face.

"No, it's fine. You have already done enough for me. And it's about time for me to start helping you, even if it's as small as paying for your food..." Yuan said. "And if I really need money, I can just farm some more monster cores and sell them again."

"Don't mention it, Brother Yuan. It's only natural for Xiao Hua to assist you as your servant. It's her responsibility, after all."

Yuan showed a gentle smile on his face and said, "Thank you, Xiao Hua. But instead of a servant, you are like a little sister to me."

"Xiao Hua... Brother Yuan's little sister? Really?" she looked at him with sparkly eyes.

"That's right." Yuan nodded. "That's why you should stop calling yourself my servant."

Xiao Hua quickly nodded with a blissful smile on her face, "Okay! Then Xiao Hua will be Brother Yuan's little sister starting now!"

Chapter 29 - Leaving Spirit City

"Xiao Hua, it's about time for me to log off for dinner. I will be back later." Yuan said to her sometime after leaving the Cultivator shop.

"Where will you go during my absence?" he then asked her.

Xiao Hua pointed to the necklace around his neck, and she said, "You can call Xiao Hua using the necklace whenever you are back."

After saying those words, Xiao Hua's body began glowing, before being absorbed into the necklace.

"What a profound necklace..." Yuan mumbled to himself before logging off.

After logging off the game, Yuan patiently waited for Yu Rou to bring him dinner, and he felt as though time had stopped.

Unlike the colorful world in the game, the real world was pitch black, almost like he was living in the void, and his body felt nonexistent.

'Haaa... If only I could live inside Cultivation Online forever...' Yuan sighed inwardly.

After familiarizing himself with the world inside the game, his perception of the real world became even worse, and it felt even more lonely than usual.

Inside the game, whether it be the pedestrians or just the noises nature made, it was always lively. However, whenever he returned to his own room, the only thing he could hear was the sound of his own heart beating and very rarely subtle noises from outside his room, a world he hasn't stepped foot in for many years.

After waiting around for a few minutes that felt like hours, he could finally hear footsteps approaching his bed.

However, he could immediately tell that it was not Yu Rou, as these footsteps were too heavy to be Yu Rou's, so it was someone else in his room.

"Who's there...?" Yuan asked in a hoarse voice.

"Young Master, the Young Lady is currently busy with the Masters, so I will be taking care of you for today." A voice belonging to a middle-aged woman responded.

"..."

"For today's dinner, we have beef soup with—"

"It's fine..." Yuan suddenly interrupted.

"I am not hungry today..."

"Even if you say that... I have a job to do..." The person sighed in a troubled tone.

"I won't... repeat myself..."

"..."

Silence filled the room, and a moment later, the middle-aged woman spoke, "I understand. Please rest well, Young Master."

The door closed a few seconds later, and Yuan could barely hear the person who just left coldly snorting in disdain.

"With that useless body, it's a miracle that he hasn't been tossed out of this house already..."

"..."

'I can still hear you, you know?' Yuan smiled bitterly.

Since the only functioning part of his body were his mouth and ears, he has to rely on his hearing more than normal people, allowing him to hear things people normally wouldn't be able to.

'Perhaps my voice, even my ability to hear might abandon me in the future, just like the rest of my body had...'

Sometime later, Yuan returned to Cultivation Online.

However, he did not immediately call for Xiao Hua, as he had spent a few minutes silently staring at this colorful world.

'What am I doing? I don't have the time to be depressed! Every second I spend idling around is a second lost in this beautiful world! I may be useless and crippled in the real world, but I am not like that in this world!'

After calming down, Yuan summoned Xiao Hua using the necklace.

"You're back already, Brother Yuan?" she looked at him with a pondering gaze.

Despite Yuan's efforts to hide his emotions, Xiao Hua was able to notice the sadness within his eyes at a single glance.

"Are you okay, Brother Yuan? You seem a bit sad." She asked him.

"Don't worry about it. It's nothing I can't handle, and it'll quickly go away after I slay a few monsters!" He said.

Although she was worried, Xiao Hua did not want to force him.

"If Brother Yuan needs somebody to talk to, Xiao Hua will always be by your side."

"Thank you, Xiao Hua. I will keep that in mind." Yuan smiled.

Xiao Hua nodded, and she said, "Then let's continue Brother Yuan's training. Although you won't gain much from Monsters Cores at the Spirit Apprentice levels, you can still improve your sword techniques. And once you are more experienced in combat, we can start looking for monsters at the Spirit Warrior realm."

"Then what are we waiting for? Let's start training!"

Yuan and Xiao Hua began making their way out of the city.

Sometime later, once they were a few miles away from the city, Xiao Hua spoke in a low voice, "Brother Yuan, we are being followed."

"Could it be the Du Brothers from the Auction House? Xuan Wuhan did warn me that those two might be up to something before we separated."

Xiao Hua nodded and said, "Yes, but I can sense another person with them. He's a Cultivator at the peak of the Spirit Master realm."

"Spirit Master? That's one realm above me..." Yuan showed a worried expression, completely forgetting about the Spirit King walking beside him.

"Don't worry, Brother Yuan. If they try to do anything funny, Xiao Hua will take care of them. Let's just continue acting like we are unaware of their presence."

Yuan nodded, and the two of them delved deeper into the wilderness.

After walking for a few more miles, a familiar-sounding voice resounded.

"Stop right there, you little bastard!"

Yuan and Xiao Hua stopped walking and turned around, and standing a few meters behind them were the Du Brothers and a tall middle-aged man with a bulky frame.

"Following me all the way out here, what do you want from me? I doubt it's anything good, though." Yuan asked them with a frown on his face.

"Since you dared to ruin my face in the Auction House before so many people and even directly in front of Lady Xuan's presence, I will have you pay for it with your life!" Du Hai spoke loudly, his face filled with anger.

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Chapter 30 - One Against Two

"Wait a second, what do you mean I ruined your face? Your face looks perfectly fine! I didn't even touch you!" Yuan said with a bewildered expression. "If you are going to lie, at least do it better!"

"Th-That's not what I mean! Are you making fun of me, you bastard?!" Du Hai stomped his feet in anger, and he continued, "Because of you, my reputation was ruined! You even embarrassed me in front of Lady Xuan! I won't forgive you even if you die!"

"What an exaggeration. If you are going to kill someone just because they embarrassed you a little bit, you'll have to kill a lot of people in the future. That's going to be a hard lifestyle." Yuan shook his head, and he was unable to comprehend the thought process of these kinds of people.

"So what?! I have already killed tons of people for messing with me, and it'll only get easier in the future! This is a world where the strong eats the weak and where the weak has no privilege to complain!"

Yuan frowned and said, "I don't care what kind of psychopathic world you live in, but I am not in a good mood today, so you should leave me out of it before I get angry."

"Hahahaha!"

The Du Brothers burst out laughing at his words, and they spoke, "So what if you get angry?!"

"What are you going to do to us?!"

"What CAN you do to us?! You are a mere single Spirit Warrior, and we have two Spirit Warriors and one peak Spirit Master!"

"Hahaha! I cannot believe that a nobody like you could be so entertaining!"

"Well, since you made us laugh, we'll give you a quick and painless death."

The Du Brothers withdrew their swords and pointed them at Yuan.

"..."

Yuan silently stared at the Du Brothers with a grim expression, his aura slowly growing sharper and sharper, almost like a sword.

When the Spirit Master saw this, he frowned and said to Du Brothers, "Young Masters, don't underestimate him. He's emitting a powerful aura that doesn't suit his level. He might have the strength to fight those above his own level."

"So what if he can fight people above his own level? We can also do the same!" Du Bai scoffed.

"Are you looking down on us? Even though you are at the Spirit Master level, you are still just a mere guard that's hired by my family!"

Meanwhile, on the opposite side, Yuan asked Xiao Hua, "Do you think I will be able to win against those two?"

"Both of them are in the fifth level Spirit Warrior realm. Although they are slightly better than the disciple you defeated before, it shouldn't be a problem for Brother Yuan."

"That's all I need to hear." Yuan nodded before retrieving his own sword.

"Oh? You also have a peak Spirit-grade weapon? I guess you really didn't wander into the VIP Room by accident! Hahahaha!"

"However, unfortunately for you, having that sword won't change the outcome!"

The Du Brothers then sheathed their swords and pulled out two peak Spirit-grade swords a few seconds later.

"I am going to warn you two one last time! Do not force my hands!" Yuan shouted at them with the sword in his hand tightly grasped.

"Enough bullshitting! Let's get him, Du Bai!"

Du Bai nodded, and the two of them began rushing at Yuan.

"This will be fun!" A wide grin appeared on Yuan's face as he also stepped forward.

A moment later, the three of them clashed, and Yuan maneuvered his sword like an expert, blocking both their sword strikes at once.

"Let's see how long you can keep this up!"

The Du Brothers began releasing a torrent of sword strikes at Yuan.

Ding! Ding! Ding!

However, Yuan either deflected their attacks or perfectly blocked them, albeit barely.

'This is much more difficult than I'd expected! If I want to win this fight, I will have to be the aggressive one!"

After being on the defensive side for a few more strikes, Yuan suddenly stepped forward and began attacking the Du Brothers, catching them off guard.

'What powerful blows!'

'He's not an ordinary one!'

The Du Brothers began sweating after tasting just a few of Yuan's sword strikes.

Meanwhile, Xiao Hua was not even paying attention to their fight, and she had her eyes on the Spirit Master this entire time, as she was prepared to kill him the moment he even tries to interfere with Yuan's fight.

'Just who is this brat? Which Family does he belong to? To think he'd be able to fight the Du Brothers by himself! And it even looks like he's slowly defeating them!' The Spirit Master watched their fight with wide eyes filled with disbelief, and he began worrying that they might have picked the wrong person to fight with.

"..."

The longer the Spirit Master watched Yuan's fight, the more shocked and worried he became.

'This young man is a genius! He's not only fighting back the Young Masters, but he's even growing stronger as he fights! He's a freaking monster! I cannot allow this to continue any longer, or the Young Masters will be in danger!'

The Spirit Master prepared to interrupt the fight, but he suddenly noticed an immense pressure not too far away, causing his eyes to shift to the small figure a few meters away, who was staring dagger at him.

'That little girl... she's an expert like me!'

The Spirit Master's back was instantly soaked in cold sweat after this realization. Anyone would think she was Yuan's little sister at glance, but to think that she would be his guardian instead! It was truly a shocking revelation!

And he was certain that this little girl's cultivation base was much more formidable than his own, as not even Spirit Grandmasters would be able to emit such a terrifying invisible pressure.

However, he cannot just stand there and watch the Du Brothers die to Yuan, as their parents would surely kill him for failing to protect them.

Chapter 31 - Negotiations

"Young Lady, why don't we talk about this?" The Spirit Master took the initiative to speak with Xiao Hua, as he was certain that he would not be able to defeat Xiao Hua in a fight, and if the Du Brothers continued fighting Yuan, they would also lose to him sooner or later and lose their lives.

With no more options at hand, he could only resort to pleading for their forgiveness, hoping that they would at least spare the Du Brothers' lives.

And he said, "Why don't we negotiate? If you let the Young Masters leave this place in one piece, the Du Family will compensate you for the trouble they have caused for your Young Master."

"Let them go... you say? But they were the ones who willingly jumped at Brother Yuan." Xiao Hua responded with a nonchalant expression.

"I won't deny that the Young Masters are the ones at fault here, but you gain nothing by killing them. In fact, if you kill them, regardless of your background, the Du Family will do everything in their power to avenge their deaths, and I'm sure neither of you would want the entire Du Family chasing after you."

"The Du Family? I have never heard of them before." Xiao Hua said.

"..."

The Spirit Master was dumbfounded. Although the Du Family is not the most powerful family in the world, they are considerably famous in the Cultivation world with multiple experts at the rank of Spirit Grandmaster within their family, and even if someone does not know of their achievements, they would at least know of their reputation.

"Furthermore, if I kill all three of you, how will the Du Family know who killed you? Even if one of you managed to escape, do you even know who we are? How are you going to find us?" Xiao Hua asked him with a cold gaze that did not fit her childish appearance.

The Spirit Master's complexion immediately paled after hearing Xiao Hua's word, and he began to realize the gravity of their situation. If Xiao Hua kills the Du Brothers including him, who will tell the Du Family about the culprits? Unless they can talk to ghosts, they will never find out the truth!

"P-Please, have mercy, Young Lady! There is no need to spill blood over such a minor complication, right? At the end of the day, those two are only Juniors who allowed their arrogance and pride to go to their head! There are many people like them out there, and I'm sure that even your Young Master has made mistakes before!" The Spirit Master began pleading, and if not for Xiao Hua's pressure on him, he would've kowtowed to her.

"Don't compare Brother Yuan to those two bullies! He's a kind brother who played with Xiao Hua when nobody else would!" Xiao Hua suddenly shouted, accidentally emitting killing intent, which suffocated the Spirit Master.

"I... can't... breathe...!" The Spirit Master began choking.

Meanwhile, right as Yuan knocked the Du Brothers to the ground, he noticed the ominous aura behind him, causing him to turn around and look.

"Xiao Hua!"

When he saw the unpleasant expression on Xiao Hua's face, his initial thought was that the Spirit Master had done something to her, so he ignored the Du Brothers and immediately rushed to her side.

"Are you okay, Xiao Hua?!"

"Hm?" Hearing Yuan's voice, Xiao Hua snapped out of her rage and turned to look at him, who was staring at her with a worried expression.

"Are you hurt anywhere?!" he asked her, and she nodded.

"Xiao Hua is okay, Brother Yuan."

"Is that so? That's great to hear," he sighed in relief.

After knowing that Xiao Hua was safe, Yuan finally noticed the Spirit Master that was laying on the ground, who was heavily panting, almost as he'd just ran a marathon.

"What happened to him?" he mumbled to Xiao Hua.

"Xiao Hua doesn't know." She casually shrugged.

After catching his breath, the Spirit Master spoke, "Please... I beg you... don't kill us..."

"That is not for me to decide." Xiao Hua said, and then she turned to look at Yuan, who appeared to be dumbfounded.

"What is he talking about? Why would I kill them?" Yuan asked.

"Eh? You're not going to kill us?" The Spirit Master looked at him with wide eyes filled with shock.

"Of course, not. While I am slightly angry about everything today, I am not like some people, who would kill another just because they were offended. However, that isn't to say I would never kill anyone because even I have a limit." Yuan said to him.

"T-Thank you, Young Master! Thank you for having mercy! I will immediately leave with those two, and we will never appear before you again!" The Spirit Master kowtowed to him with tears in his eyes.

"Wait a second! Who said you can leave so fast?" Yuan suddenly said.

"Huh?" The Spirit Master looked at him with wide eyes.

"I have unexpectedly used up most of my energy after fighting with those two, and I'd spend 500 gold coins filling up my stomach not long ago. Now I feel like I wasted my money. How are you going to compensate me for this tragedy?" Yuan said to him with a frown.

"..."

Not just the Spirit Master, but even Xiao Hua was staring at him with wide eyes filled with shock.

"O-Of course... Although this isn't much because the Young Masters had already used most of it, I will give you all of it..."

The Spirit Master quickly retrieved his money pouch and offered it to Yuan as though he was giving an offering to a God.

'I never thought a day where I would become a victim of extortion would come—and it's even to a mere Spirit Warrior Junior!' he cried inwardly, feeling his pride as a Spirit Master shattering into a thousand pieces.

Yuan cleared his throat and accepted the money pouch without a hint of shame on his face, and he spoke afterward, "Thank you for the donation."

'Donation, my ass!' The Spirit Master retorted inwardly, but he didn't dare to complain out loud, as he feared that Yuan might change his mind and kill all of them.

"You may leave now."

After receiving Yuan's permission, the Spirit Master immediately went to grab the Du Brothers and quickly left the scene.

"W-Wait a minute! Where are you taking us?! We haven't lost to him yet!"

"Let me fight him! I won't be able to sleep tonight if I don't beat him up!"

The Du Brothers struggled to escape the Spirit Master's grasp, but being an entire realm below him, they were effortlessly taken away by him, disappearing a few moments later.

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Chapter 32 - Sword Aura

After the Spirit Master and the Du Brothers are long gone, Xiao Hua spoke, "Brother Yuan, why did you let them leave? Knowing their personalities, the Du Brothers definitely won't forgive you for what happened today, and they will surely come back even stronger for revenge one day."

"Xiao Hua is aware of Brother Yuan's kind personality, and Brother Yuan only very recently became a Cultivator, so killing people might still be difficult for you, but there are people in this world that are better off dead. Because even if they no longer pose any threat to you, they will surely be a threat to someone else."

"The Cultivation world is a place where if you do not consume your enemies, they will eventually consume you instead. So you must become the one who consumes others, not the other way around."

Hearing Xiao Hua's lecture, Yuan sighed, "I know that I may be naive, perhaps even a fool in your eyes, and that these people are only NPCs within a game, but I do not wish to kill another human being unless absolutely necessary, as I am afraid that it might affect my mind negatively, since there has already been a few times where I forgot that I am actually inside a video game, treating this world as though it's the real world."

"..."

Xiao Hua listened to his words in silence. And although she only understood half of it, she knew what he was trying to say, and she said afterward, "Brother Yuan, what you have experienced today is barely the tip of the Cultivation world and very common in our world. There will be many more people like the Du Brothers out there, and there will even be people with far worse personalities. You will also encounter similar

situations in the future, sometimes more than once in a single day. And unless you are strong — strong enough to handle any situation that comes your way, you will always be bullied by the strong and powerful ones."

A bitter smile appeared on Yuan's face.

"I guess living life as a Cultivator isn't as easy as I initially thought. I just hope that I won't become someone without morals or someone who is apathetic to other peoples' life like the Du Brothers."

"Don't worry, Brother Yuan. If you ever walk astray in your Cultivation path or feel like you are becoming a different person, Xiao Hua will be there to help you return back to normal."

"Thank you, Xiao Hua. I will also try my best to familiarize myself with this new world and lifestyle as a Cultivator without being a burden for you."

"People will always change, but it's how they change that truly matters. As long as Brother Yuan remains the kind brother that he is right now, it will be fine even if you change a little." Xiao Hua said to him.

"Hahaha... You are really like my little sister, who is actually more mature and intelligent than she appears." Yuan chuckled, feeling as though he could see Yu Rou in Xiao Hua's shadow.

"Anyway, how's Brother Yuan feeling? Were you injured during your fight with the Du Brothers?" Xiao Hua asked him sometime later.

"Besides having a few superficial scratches and feeling a little bit hungry again, I'm perfectly fine." He said with an energetic expression.

Xiao Hua nodded and continued to speak, "Brother Yuan's experience and insight have increased significantly from the fight. If we continue at this rate, Brother Yuan should be prepared to fight monsters at the Spirit Warrior level in no time."

"Then what are we waiting for? Let's continue training!" Yuan said with enthusiasm.

"Brother Yuan really likes to fight, huh?" Xiao Hua said with a smile.

"Of course, since I feel like I am actually alive when I fight. I also enjoy moving my body, swinging a sword around, and the thrill that comes from fighting." Yuan nodded.

The two of them began walking deeper into the wilderness shortly later, and Yuan would continue sharpening his sword skills while Xiao Hua assisted by locating all of the monsters for him.

After many hours of training with the sword, a notification appeared before Yuan.

«Your mastery with the sword has improved significantly»

«Your understanding of swords has reached a new level»

«You have met the criteria to learn 'Sword Aura'»

'Sword Aura...?'

Yuan raised his eyebrows at this new term.

"Xiao Hua, what's Sword Aura?" He decided to ask the only expert available.

"Sword Aura?! Has Brother Yuan's swordsmanship reached the level where he can already learn Sword Aura?!" Xiao Hua looked at him with a shocked face.

"I don't even know what that is... But after listening to your tone, I'm guessing it's something impressive?"

"Of course, it's something impressive! Only true swordsmen can learn Sword Aura! And it's not something one can learn just by training with a sword, as you can train with a sword for your entire life and not understand Sword Aura, whilst some people can do it within a few years of training! People with Sword Aura are also called Swordmasters! However, Brother Yuan has only trained with the sword for only a few days! If people learn of

your talent, there will be countless Swordmasters who will beg you to become their disciple!" Xiao Hua said to him with excitement.

"You're praising me too much, again... It's making me blush..." Yuan said with a slightly rosy face.

"Then can you teach me how to use this Sword Aura?" he asked her a moment later.

Xiao Hua shook her head and said, "That's not possible for Xiao Hua because she is not a Swordmaster, so she does not understand Sword Aura."

"I see... Then how do people normally learn Sword Aura?"

"Through training, Brother Yuan. Once you grasp the understanding of Sword Aura, it's only a matter of time before you learn it. In fact, all Swordmasters will eventually learn Sword Aura as long as they keep training with the sword." Xiao Hua said.

"Then I don't have to do anything special?"

Yuan asked, and Xiao Hua shook her head.

'I wonder how long it'll take for me to learn Sword Aura...' Yuan pondered to himself as he stared at the sword in his hand with a dazed expression.

'If the Du Brothers really decide to return for revenge, I will be ready for them, and I won't let them escape a second time.'

Chapter 33 - Monster Slayer

After meeting the criteria for learning Sword Aura, Yuan and Xiao Hua continued to hunt monsters for a few hours.

"I have been training with the sword nonstop for five hours now, but I still cannot seem to learn this Sword Aura..." Yuan sighed.

"It would be more shocking if Brother Yuan actually learns Sword Aura in such a short time. Even the top geniuses in the Higher Heavens need to train for many years before they can learn Sword Aura." Xiao Hua said to him.

"There's no need to be impatient, Brother Yuan. You are without a doubt a genius that was born with a high affinity with swords. If you train enough, you'll definitely learn Sword Aura sooner or later."

Yuan nodded, and they returned to hunting more monsters.

After killing a few monsters, a notification appeared before Yuan.

«Congratulations, you have slain a total of 1,000 monsters»

«You have gained the title 'Novice Monster Slayer»

«Because of your title 'Novice Monster Slayer', all of your damage dealt to monsters will be increased by 10%. Monsters will feel more pain from your attacks as your damage to them increases.»

'This is my second title, and it even comes with a very beneficial effect.' Yuan wondered to himself if Titles are a common thing in Cultivation Online. Of course, due to the lack of guides for this game, he cannot know for sure without talking to other people or looking it up online.

Sometime later, Xiao Hua suddenly stopped moving and said, "Brother Yuan, there's a person ahead of us."

"Oh? What's he doing?" Yuan asked.

"He seems to be pacing back and forth in front of this cave entrance with a distressful expression on his face."

Hearing Xiao Hua's words, Yuan pondered, 'Is he an NPC or a Player?'

"Let's go see the situation. If he's truly that worried, maybe there's something we can do to help him." He said.

Xiao Hua nodded, and they made their way toward this cave entrance.

A few minutes later, a middle-aged man with a pale complexion entered their view, and the middle-aged man noticed them at the same time.

"Ah! It appears that my pleading has finally reached the Heavens! Please, Esteemed Cultivators, I need your help!" The middle-aged man quickly approached them with teary eyes and a desperate expression.

"What's the matter?" Yuan asked him.

"My daughter— she was captured by a fearsome monster and was taken inside the cave! Please, can you help me by bringing her back?! I will do anything in return for your help! Please, Saviors!" The middle-aged man even got on his knees and kowtowed to Yuan.

«You have received a Quest»

«Quest: Unknown Man's Plea»

«Location: Demonic Spider's Silent Cave»

«Difficulty: Medium»

«Quest Description: Help the man by rescuing his daughter from the Demonic Spider»

'A Quest?' Yuan was immediately intrigued, as this is his first time encountering a normal quest.

"Xiao Hua, what's a Demonic Spider?" he decided to ask her first.

"Demonic Spiders are intelligent and deceptive monsters that mostly dwell within caves like this one, and they are usually within the Spirit Warrior levels." Xiao Hua said to him.

"Do you think I can defeat a Demonic Spider at my current level?"

Xiao Hua nodded, "As long as its cultivation is below the third level, it shouldn't be a problem for Brother Yuan."

Yuan sighed in relief after hearing her words, and he looked at the middle-aged man and said, "Okay, we'll help you rescue your daughter."

«You have accepted the Quest 'Unknown Man's Plea'»

"Oh! Thank you! Thank you very much, brave warrior!"

"You can thank me after I return with your daughter," Yuan said to him before he approached the cave.

«You are about to enter 'Demonic Spider's Silent Cave»

«Recommended Level: Third level Spirit Warrior and above»

"Let's go, Xiao Hua," Yuan said to her, who nodded with a mysterious glint in her gaze.

Once Yuan and Xiao Hua entered the cave shortly later, the middle-aged man standing outside cried inwardly: 'Finally! I am finally free!'

"This place isn't as dark as I'd expected," Yuan said after realizing that he was able to see inside clearly despite how dark it looked from outside.

"That's because all of Brother Yuan's senses have improved after becoming a Cultivator." Xiao Hua said.

And then she continued, "By the way, Brother Yuan should be careful."

"Huh? Can you already sense the Demonic Spider?"

However, Xiao Hua shook her head and said, "That man outside... he lied to us."

Yuan's eyes widened with surprise after hearing such words, and he asked, "W-What do you mean by that? Why would he lie to us? And how can you tell?"

"Because Xiao Hua has already searched this entire cave with her spiritual sense, and she was unable to sense the man's 'daughter' inside this place. However, there is a Demonic Spider in here."

"But the despair in his eyes seemed so real, and so was his tears... What if the Demonic Spider has already eaten his daughter?" Yuan asked, still feeling slightly doubtful.

"That's not possible, because Xiao Hua would've been able to sense her blood. Perhaps the man outside is working for the Demonic Spider by luring people into this place for it. After all, Demonic Spiders are very crafty and intelligent beings. It's not uncommon for them to use humans to bait other humans into their dwelling."

"No way..." Yuan stopped moving and stood there with a dazed expression on his face. He didn't doubt the man even for a second because of the Quest. If the man had really tricked them, why would a Quest appear, even asking him to save his daughter? It made no sense at all.

"Then should we turn around and leave this place?" Yuan asked her.

"We could do that, but doesn't Brother Yuan want to fight a monster at the Spirit Warrior level? This could be a good opportunity for Brother Yuan—at least Xiao Hua thinks so."

"You think so...?" Yuan showed a bitter smile on his face.

Should he continue on with this Quest that might be a trap, or should he just turn around and call it quits?

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Chapter 34 - Demonic Spider

"..."

After standing there with a pondering face for some time, Yuan finally said, "Okay, let's do this. Even if that man may have lured us into this trap, if I leave now, who knows how many more people will fall victim to this scheme if I leave it alone."

"Tell me more about the Demonic Spider, Xiao Hua. Does it have any fatal weaknesses?"

Xiao Hua nodded and said, "Demonic Spiders are renowned for their powerful poison, which can easily kill someone below the Spirit Warrior level within mere seconds, and their sharp claws that can cut large boulders as though it's paper. However, as long as you avoid these two deadly attacks, the Demonic Spider is no different than just an oversized spider."

"...You make it sound like it's an easy task to dodge those attacks." Yuan looked at her with raised eyebrows.

"Although the Demonic Spider has powerful attacks, it lacks the speed to take advantage of its raw power. So as long as Brother Yuan pays attention, you shouldn't have any problems dodging its attacks."

"I hope so..." Yuan sighed.

The two of them began walking deeper into the cave until they encountered what appeared to be an entrance to another area in the cave.

"This is definitely the boss room..." Yuan mumbled to himself after seeing the suspicious entrance that oozed with an obnoxious feeling.

"The Demonic Spider is right beyond that point, Brother Yuan, and it appears to be at the fourth level Spirit Warrior realm." Xiao Hua said to him after scouting for him using her spiritual sense.

"Fourth level... That's one level higher than your recommended level..." Yuan said.

"Brother Yuan is a genius so it will be fine." Xiao Hua raised her thumb at him.

"I have a feeling that you are overestimating me..."

"Don't worry, Brother Yuan. If you are in trouble, Xiao Hua will come to your rescue, so you can fight to your heart's content."

"I guess so... What's the worst that can happen? I die and restart my cultivation? Well, here goes nothing."

After taking a moment to prepare himself mentally, Yuan began walking towards the boss room with a sword in his hand.

After entering the boss room, Yuan could see a spacious area with webs and bones littering the ground, but there was no sight of the Demonic Spider.

"Where's the Demonic Spider?" he asked after looking left and right without seeing the monster.

"It's above you, Brother Yuan." Xiao Hua said to him.

"Why didn't you tell me that before I entered this room?!" Yuan immediately looked up at the ceiling, where a 5-meter tall monster with a half-human and half-body spider was hanging on the webs that covered the entire cave ceiling.

"That thing is massive!" Yuan exclaimed with a terrified expression, as he has never seen anything this terrifying before.

Not only did it look like a monster straight out of a horror movie, but it also had eight massive and sharp legs, and each of them was as big as Yuan's

entire body.

"Be careful, Brother Yuan! It's coming!"

Right as Xiao Hua warned him, the Demonic Spider kicked its legs and jumped at Yuan with its large mouth wide open.

"Oh shit!" Yuan quickly jumped back.

Boom!

The Demonic Spider landed a moment later, destroying the solid ground with ease.

"Looks like we have quite the nimble one here." The Demonic Spider suddenly spoke in a hoarse voice.

"It can speak?!" Yuan was thoroughly shocked now, as he did not expect the Demonic Spider to suddenly start speaking in human language.

"Some demonic beings can gain the ability to speak once they reach a certain cultivation level." Xiao Hua said to him.

"Since it can speak, I might as well question it!" Yuan said, and he continued, "Demonic Spider! What happened to the daughter of the man outside?!"

"What... you ask? I ate her, of course.... Hahaha!" The Demonic Spider burst out laughing, sending chills down Yuan's body.

"Children's meat smells and tastes the best, after all! Although I'd promised that man that I'd return his daughter if he brings me 10 humans, I simply couldn't resist my urges, and I consumed her flesh and bones on the second day!" The Demonic Spider held a blissful expression on its human-like face as it recalled eating the human girl.

"You bastard..." Yuan narrowed his eyes in anger, and he emitted killing intent for the first time ever.

«You have gained new information for the Quest 'Unknown Man's Plea'»

«Quest 'Unknown Man's Plea' has been updated»

«Quest Description: Slay the Demonic Spider that consumed the man's daughter»

"I like the look in your eyes — it resembles that of a wild beast..." A grin appeared on the Demonic Spider's face, and it continued to speak, "However, you are only at the first level Spirit Warrior realm. You cannot defeat me, so you should just give up and let me eat you."

The Demonic Spider then turned to look at Xiao Hua and said, " This is truly my lucky day. Your skin is very smooth and beautiful; it also smells much better than the other child. I bet you are going to taste much better, too."

The smile on its face grew even wider when it imagined taking a bite from Xiao Hua's tempting body.

"Since you like to eat so much, I will let you eat my sword!"

Yuan shouted, and he rushed at the Demonic Spider with the sword in his hands raised.

"Bloody Sword Strike!"

A red aura covered the sword's blade, creating a red arc of sword light as it slashed towards the Demonic Spider.

Ding!

The Demonic Spider quickly blocked the Yuan's strike with one of its legs, and the impact made it sound as though two swords had collided.

'It's tough!' Yuan was surprised by how hard the Demonic Spider's legs were, feeling as though they were made out of metal.

However, Yuan was not the only one who was surprised after that exchange, as the Demonic Spider was also shocked by Yuan's strength.

'How does this human have such strength when he's only at the first level Spirit Warrior realm?! He'd even managed to cut my legs that are harder than steel in a single strike!' The Demonic Spider looked at the sword cut with wide eyes filled with shock.

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Chapter 35 - Poison Sac

"Looks like you have some ability, Cultivator." The Demonic Spider showed him a grotesque smile and continued, "However, you won't be able to defeat me if that's all of your strength."

"You talk too much for a monster!" Yuan said, and he rushed at the Demonic Spider again.

"How brave!" The Demonic Spider used its legs to sweep at Yuan, but he dodged it with ease.

'Just as Xiao Hua said! Although it may be strong and tough, its speed is very slow compared to the Cultivators I've already fought!' Yuan felt relieved inwardly after seeing that he could dodge the Demonic Spider's attacks with no problem.

"Bloody Sword Strike!"

Yuan activated his sword skill, and he aimed it directly at the Demonic Spider's face.

"If I can't cut your legs, I will go straight for your face!"

Ding!

The Demonic Spider used two more legs to block its face.

"Hahaha! Did you forget that I have eight limbs?! Die for me!"

After blocking Yuan's attack, the Demonic Spider opened its mouth and spat out a lob of green liquid at him.

Yuan's eyes widened at the green liquid that was flying towards his face, but he was not caught off guard, as he'd been watching the Demonic Spider's every movement very carefully.

After dodging the poison spit, Yuan distanced himself from the Demonic Spider and raised his sword in a particular manner.

"I do not believe that I cannot cut you down!"

Yuan took a deep breath before closing his eyes.

"How dare you close your eyes during our fight?! Are you looking down on me?!" The Demonic Spider shouted in anger, and it began running at Yuan with a fierce aura.

However, Yuan remained calm, and he slowly opened his eyes a second later, which was glowing brilliantly, and his black eyes suddenly became golden.

When the Demonic Spider saw Yuan's golden eyes, it immediately stopped running at him and stared at him with narrowed eyes, feeling an ominous feeling coming from Yuan.

'This is my first time using this skill, but I have a feeling that it'll defeat the Demonic Spider.' Yuan felt very confident at this moment, and his senses were sharper, almost as though something within him had awakened.

'Oh? Brother Yuan is finally going to use that technique?' Xiao Hua watched with enthusiasm.

Yuan's body suddenly exploded with immense spiritual energy and a heavenly aura, and his sword gushed with a golden light that was so bright and thick that the blade itself could no longer be seen, almost as though it'd turned into a pillar of light.

After raising the sword towards the heavens, Yuan swung it vertically as though he wanted to split the seas and separate the heavens.

"Heaven Splitting Sword Strike!"

A golden beam of light then shot out from the sword and rushed at the Demonic Spider, and if one looked closely, they would be able to see the image of a dragon within the golden light.

The Demonic Spider watched the golden beam flying towards it with wide eyes, and it wanted to dodge it, but for some odd reason, it was unable to move its muscles, much less its legs, almost as though there were invisible chains bounding its body.

The Demonic Spider suddenly felt the urge to turn its head, so it slowly turned to look at the small figure standing a few meters away, and when it saw the barely noticeable smile on Xiao Hua's face, it immediately realized why it couldn't move its body, and it roared loudly.

"AAAAAHHHHHH! DAMN YOU, HUMANS!"

When the golden light finally reached the Demonic Spider, it consumed the Demonic Spider's figure, before destroying its body into a million pieces until there was nothing left of its existence.

However, the golden light did not stop even after erasing the Demonic Spider and continued to fly towards the end of the cave.

BOOM!

The entire cave shook violently as Yuan's sword strike created a massive hole in the cave.

«Congratulations! Player Yuan has become the first player to kill the Elite Boss: Demonic Spider»

«Congratulations! Player Yuan has become the first player to conquer the Demonic Spider's Silent Cave!»

Two announcements appeared in the sky for every Player in the world to see.

Meanwhile, inside the Demonic Spider's Silent Cave, Yuan silently stared at the gaping hole in the cave, seemingly surprised by the Heaven Splitting

Sword Strike's prowess.

"As expected of a Divine-rank Skill, its ability is through the roof..." Yuan mumbled in a dazed voice.

Sometime later, Xiao Hua approached Yuan with two items in her hand, and she said, "Brother Yuan, the Demonic Spider dropped its Monster Core and a Poison Sac."

"Oh, thank you..." Yuan accepted the Monster Core without hesitation but then looked at the Poison Sac with a worried expression.

"Xiao Hua, is it safe to be holding that thing?" he asked her.

"Un. The poison is contained inside the sac, so you won't get poisoned." She nodded.

«Poison Sac»

«Material»

«Description: A rare item dropped by Demonic Spiders. It can be used to enchant weapons or used to create poison pills»

"Anyway, let's get out of here," Yuan said.

The two of them began making their way out of the cave, and a few minutes later, they reached the exit.

"Y-You are! What happened?! Where's my daughter?!"

When the middle-aged man saw Yuan, his eyes widened with shock.

Why is he still alive? What happened to the Demonic Spider?

Seeing the middle-aged man, Yuan immediately frowned and said to him, "How dare you lie and bait us! You never wanted us to save your daughter!"

The middle-aged man immediately got on his knees and kowtowed to them, "I'm sorry, Cultivators! I had no choice because the Demonic Spider has my daughter! It said that if I brought ten humans to it, it would let my daughter live!"

Yuan shook his head and said, "Just like how you'd lied to us, the Demonic Spider also lied to you. It never planned on keeping its words. Your daughter... she was eaten by it on the second day."

"N-No! Impossible!"

The middle-aged man looked at Yuan with disbelief, and he begged Yuan in a voice filled with desperation, "Please! That cannot be true! She must be in there somewhere!"

"I don't gain anything by lying to you. If you do not believe me, you can go inside and check for yourself. I have already killed the Demonic Spider, so you don't have to worry about—"

Before Yuan could even finish his sentence, the middle-aged man got up and rushed into the cave, disappearing into the darkness.

Chapter 36 - Consuming The Demonic Spider's Monster Core

Chapter 36 - Consuming The Demonic Spider's Monster Core

Many minutes have passed since the middle-aged man rushed inside the Demonic Spider's Silent Cave to look for his daughter.

Meanwhile, Yuan and Xiao Hua waited for him outside.

'I wonder how much Qi I will gain by consuming the Demonic Spider's monster core.' Yuan thought to himself with the shiny monster core in his hands, preparing to pop it into his mouth like eating hard candy.

When Xiao Hua noticed Yuan staring at the Demonic Spider's monster core with craving eyes, she asked him, "Brother Yuan, are you going to eat the monster core...? Although Brother Yuan can eat Spirit Apprentice level monster cores without any problems, Xiao Hua is worried that Spirit Warrior level monster cores may contain too much Qi for you to consume..."

"We won't know that until I try it, right?" Yuan said.

"That is true, but..." Xiao Hua still wore a worried expression.

Yuan then said with a confident smile, "Don't worry, Xiao Hua. I have faith in my stomach!"

"But the Qi goes to your Dantian, not your stomach, Brother Yuan... It's not food, after all." Xiao Hua said to him with a dumbfounded face.

"What's the difference?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"The Dantian is every Cultivator's source of power and where you store your Qi. Without it, one cannot cultivate Qi. And any damage done to one's

Dantian is incredibly hard to heal, that's why every Cultivator cares for their Dantian more than their own life because they rather die than live life as a cripple." Xiao Hua explained to him the importance of one's Dantian.

"If one cannot cultivate, they are considered a cripple in this world? And people would rather die than to live as a 'cripple'? That's bullshit!" Yuan looked at her with wide eyes filled with disbelief, even feeling slightly angry at Cultivators.

As a cripple himself, Yuan couldn't help but feel offended to hear that Cultivators would rather die than being a 'cripple'. In fact, he doesn't even consider people who cannot cultivate to be real cripples, even finding it incredibly disrespectful.

"So what if one cannot Cultivate? That does not mean they should die! These Cultivators truly live a luxurious life, worrying about such insignificant matters!" Yuan sighed loudly.

"..." Xiao Hua was speechless.

Although it may not be of any importance to Yuan who grew up in a world without any Cultivation and in a relatively peaceful world, in the Cultivation world, whether one can cultivate or not was a matter of life or death, because if one cannot cultivate they will remain weak forever and will eventually be consumed by the stronger people who can cultivate.

'Brother Yuan may not understand the importance of Cultivation now, but once he grows stronger and experiences more of the Cultivation world, he'll see the real ugliness of this world.' Xiao Hua pondered to herself.

And while Xiao Hua was thinking to herself, Yuan tossed the monster core in his mouth.

"Brother Yuan!" Xiao Hua's heart skipped a beat after seeing this. No matter how many times she has witnessed Yuan eating monster cores, she could not get used to such an abnormal scene and would always feel nervous afterward.

"Calm down, Xiao Hua. I am fine." Yuan said to her as he savored the sweet taste in his mouth. Just like Spirit Apprentice level monster cores, the Demonic Spider monster core melted into a sweet substance the moment it touched his tongue.

After swallowing the Demonic Spider's monster core, Yuan could feel an enormous power growing from within his body, causing his aura and cultivation to skyrocket.

«Heaven Refining Physique activated»

«153,840,000 Qi has been refined from the Demonic Spider's monster core»

38,460,000/38,460,000

«You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough»

«You have reached the Second Level Spirit Warrior»

«+1,500 Stats»

70,692,000/70,692,000

«You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough»

«You have reached the Third Level Spirit Warrior»

«+2,000 Stats»

153,840,000/153,840,000

«You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough»

«You have reached the Fourth Level Spirit Warrior»

«+2,500 Stats»

165,568,000/307,680,000

"B-B-Brother Yuan... you... you..." Xiao Hua glared at him with a terrified expression, as she has never seen anyone raise their cultivation by three levels in a single breath.

"See? I am fine even after consuming the monster core." Yuan said to her afterward with a bright smile on his face.

'What is going on?! How can Brother Yuan raise cultivation levels as easy as breathing? Could he be the Cultivation God's reincarnate?!' Xiao Hua cried inwardly.

However, Yuan obtained more than just Qi from consuming the Demonic Spider's monster core, as his Heavenly Refining Physique unexpectedly activated again.

«Heaven Refining Physique activated»

«You have gained 'Weak Poison Resistance' from consuming the Demonic Spider's monster core»

«Weak Poison Resistance»

«Description: Slightly increases your poison resistance»

"Xiao Hua, I also gained some resistance against poison after consuming the monster core, but this has never happened before." Yuan decided to ask her, who's still trying to recover from the earlier shock.

"Brother Yuan, what did you just say...?" Xiao Hua asked him with a dazed face.

"Uh... that I gained some poison resistance after consuming the monster core?" Yuan repeated himself.

"T-That's impossible!" Xiao Hua quickly shook her head, and she continued to speak in a shocked voice, "Xiao Hua has never heard of someone gaining something else besides Qi from consuming monster cores before!"

Yuan casually shrugged his shoulder and said, "There's a saying that there's always a first time for everything."

However, Xiao Hua was not convinced, as this would be an unprecedented event in the Cultivation world that has existed for countless millions of years!

'No... there is a story in the Upper Heavens that mentions an individual who has a similar ability... but that is only a legend from the ancient times...'

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Chapter 37 - Quest Complete

"Brother Yuan is truly... unfathomable..." Xiao Hua could barely stand still at this moment, feeling as though her common sense regarding the Cultivation world had been flipped upside-down by Yuan's profound existence.

"Are you okay, Xiao Hua? Your expressions are more exaggerated than usual." Yuan suddenly said to her, completely unaware of how heaven-defying his own existence is.

"X-Xiao Hua is fine..." she nodded a moment later, and she continued, "But is Brother Yuan really fine? Does your body feel weird? You did just breakthrough three times in the blink of an eye, after all..."

"I feel perfectly fine," he said. "In fact, I feel even better than normal!"

And then he said, "By the way, Xiao Hua, remember that Spirit Crystal you bought from the auction house? Since it's similar to a monster core, maybe I can eat it too?"

When Xiao Hua heard his words, she immediately shook her head with a horrified expression and spoke in a stern voice, "Absolutely not, Brother Yuan! You cannot eat the Spirit Crystal! It contains spiritual energy that rivals even Spirit Grandmasters! And it's nothing like a monster core! Brother Yuan will definitely explode into a million pieces after eating it!"

"If you say so..." Yuan said with a slightly disappointed expression, as he was curious about the Spirit Crystal's taste.

—

A few minutes later, Xiao Hua suddenly said, "Brother Yuan, he's coming back."

Yuan turned to look at the cave, and the middle-aged man slowly walked out of the cave with an emotionless expression, almost as though he'd lost all of his will to continue living.

When Yuan saw the hopelessness in the middle-aged man's blank eyes, he also felt a slight pain in his heart, as he understood what the middle-aged man was feeling at this moment very well.

After living for so many years as a cripple who cannot even leave his own bed without another's assistance, even the world's toughest man would experience depression, much less someone as young and innocent as Yuan, and it was inevitable that he would have thoughts about ending his own life to make things easier for his little sister.

"That man... he's lost the will to live," Yuan mumbled in a low voice. "If only there's something we can do to relieve that sorrow."

Xiao Hua gently shook her head and spoke, "There is nothing we can do for him, Brother Yuan. This is the harsh reality for those without power — the weak will be consumed by the strong. There's only one way to avoid this kind of situation, and that is to become strong enough to protect the things you love."

"..."

Yuan was speechless, but he was beginning to understand this world better and why people—Cultivators thirst for power. If one was weak, they might experience the same situation as this middle-aged man, losing their loved ones to a stronger existence that's beyond their own abilities.

And somewhere within Yuan's heart, the desire for strength—the desire to protect this peaceful life he's living—began to bud.

"Ah... you're still here..." The middle-aged man stopped in front of Yuan and Xiao Hua.

"I'm sorry for your loss... If only I came to this place earlier..." Yuan sighed.

The middle-aged man shook his head and spoke in a low voice, "No, this is entirely my fault. If only I didn't bring her to this dangerous place to pick herbs with me..."

"But for poor people like us, this is the only way for us to continue living."

"Anyway, I would like to apologize for tricking you into the Demonic Spider's cave." The middle-aged man got on his knees and kowtowed to them with a sincere feeling, not daring to lift his head even many moments later.

"Please, you don't need to apologize for something you were forced to do. If I were in your shoes, I would've done the same thing." Yuan said while pulling the man off the floor.

"Then allow me to thank you for killing the Demonic Spider — for avenging my daughter's death..."

The middle-aged man reached into his pockets before taking out a beautiful plant with seven colorful leaves that resembled a rainbow.

"That's the Seven Colored Herb, Brother Yuan!" Xiao Hua immediately recognized this beautiful plant and said in an excited voice while pulling his sleeves.

"Is it valuable?" he asked.

"The Seven Colored Herb is an extremely rare medicine that does not grow in any specific location in this world! Most people live their entire life without seeing one! It's a priceless treasure!" she said.

"Are you sure that you want to part with such a precious item?" Yuan asked the middle-aged man, feeling hesitant about accepting such a priceless treasure. "Don't you need money? If you sell it..."

However, before Yuan could even finish his sentence, the middle-aged man shook his head and said, "Without my daughter, I no longer have any need

for money. And this medicine was found by my daughter. I'm sure that she would want you to have it, too."

"..."

"Please, young man, accept it." The man lowered his head and extended his arms until the Seven Colored Herb was right before Yuan's body.

Seeing this, Yuan sighed and accepted the herb.

"Thank you..."

Once Yuan accepted the Seven Colored Herb, the middle-aged bowed to him one last time before turning around and walking away.

"Please wait!" Yuan suddenly shouted at him.

When the man stopped walking and turned around, Yuan tossed a small pouch at him and said, "It may be nothing compared to your gift, but I hope you can live a carefree life for the rest of your life!"

The middle-aged man did not say anything and merely nodded his head before disappearing into the woods.

"I don't know how much money was inside that pouch since I didn't look in it after it was given to me by that Spirit Master, but I hope it was enough." Yuan sighed afterward.

"Don't worry, Brother Yuan. There was plenty of money inside." Xiao Hua said with a smile.

"Eh? How do you know? You didn't even touch it."

"A storage pouch without any protection is no different than an open book for Cultivators who can control their spiritual sense. Just like how Xiao Hua uses her spiritual sense to locate monsters for Brother Yuan, Xiao Hua can also use her spiritual sense to sense things that cannot normally be seen with the naked eyes." Xiao Hua said.

"Anyway, there were about 3,000,000 gold coins inside that pouch. But compared to the Seven Colored Herb he gave to Brother Yuan, it's akin to buying a priceless treasure with a grain of rice."

"This thing is that valuable...?" Yuan looked at the colorful plant in his grasp.

[Seven Colored Herb]

[Tier 7 Medicine]

[Description: An extremely rare herb with countless uses]

'Tier 7 medicine! Even the Soul Strengthening Pill Xuan Wuhan gave me is only Tier 3!' Yuan cried inwardly.

A few more moments later, a notification appeared before him.

«You have completed the Quest: Unknown Man's Plea»

«You have been rewarded with: 1x Seven Colored Herb»

«Fame +10»

«'Mu Qing' has been added to your Bond!»

«Mu Qing's Bond level has increased to Acquaintance!»

«Congratulations! You have gained the following effect from Mu Qing's Bond level: 'Mu Qing's Approval'»

Chapter 38 - Flying Sword

'Mu Qing's Approval...? Is Mu Qing that man just now?' Yuan raised his eyebrows in a puzzled manner after seeing the notification.

«Mu Qing's Approval: Grants you access to certain events»

'What kind of effect is this?' Yuan became even more puzzled after seeing the description.

Unlike Mo Zhou's Gratitude that grants him offensive benefits, this Mu Qing's Approval provided nothing of that sort except a vague description.

'I guess not every effect comes with benefits like Mo Zhou's Gratitude...' Yuan thought to himself.

"Xiao Hua, now that I have defeated a monster at the Spirit Warrior level, do you think I am ready to fight other monsters at the same level?" Yuan asked her sometime later.

"Un. But Spirit Warrior level monsters don't usually roam in this area. The Demonic Spider must have been a special occasion. If Brother Yuan wants to fight Spirit Warrior leveled monsters, we will have to travel further south to the Purple Bamboo Forest. There we can find monsters between the first level and the third level Spirit Warrior."

"How far away is this place?" Yuan asked.

"A few thousand miles," she casually responded.

"A few thousand?!" Yuan's eyes widened with shock, as that was akin to traveling from one continent to another in the real world! How long would it take for them to get there without a plane or any vehicle?

"Um... And how are we going to get there?" He decided to ask her.

"We fly, of course." Xiao Hua calmly responded. "Unless Brother Yuan wants to run there, which will take a couple of days."

"W-Wait a second... did you just say 'fly'? You can fly?!" Yuan looked at her with wide eyes, completely forgetting about her skills.

Xiao Hua nodded and said, "Once a Cultivator reaches the Spirit Grandmaster level, they can manipulate the spiritual energy within their body and their surroundings and soar in the sky. Of course, there are talented individuals out there who can fly before reaching the Spirit Grandmaster level."

"But since Brother Yuan can't fly yet, Xiao Hua will carry you with a flying sword."

After saying those words, Xiao Hua retrieved a sword from her storage pouch and tossed it in the air.

One would expect the gravity to pull the sword towards the ground, but the sword actually remained suspended in the air, almost as though there was an invisible hand holding it.

"Oh my god..." Yuan stared at the floating sword with bright eyes.

He has been wanting to try something like this ever since he saw that Cultivator floating in the sky while standing on his sword when he first arrived in this world. However, he didn't expect that such an opportunity would arise so fast.

"You are the best, Xiao Hua! I love you!" Yuan went to hug her out of sheer excitement.

"Oh..." Xiao Hua's soft cheeks turned slightly rosy after the hug.

"Anyway, how do I do this? Do I just jump on the sword?" Yuan asked her afterward.

"U-Un." Xiao Hua nodded, and she spoke, "Because Xiao Hua will control the sword for Brother Yuan, you will only need to control the spiritual energy in your legs and feet, or you will fall off the sword in the air."

"Okay, let's give this a try!"

Yuan immediately turned to face the flying sword with excitement in his gaze.

After preparing himself, he jumped on the sword.

"Ah!"

Yuan immediately fell off the sword a second later due to a mistake in his balancing.

"This is harder than I'd thought..." Yuan said, but he did not lose hope and tried again.

"Ack!"

"Ugh!"

"Oof!"

After many trials and errors that resulted in his face kissing the ground, Yuan finally began getting used to controlling his spiritual energy and balancing himself on the sword.

"Look! I am floating!" Yuan spoke with excitement after standing on the flying sword without falling for over a minute.

Seeing this Xiao Hua said, "Xiao Hua will move the sword now. Try to stay on the sword, Brother Yuan."

"Do it slowly!" He quickly warned her.

A second later, the flying sword began moving very slowly, traveling a single meter every few seconds.

"Hahaha! I am doing—"

Just as Yuan prepared to celebrate his achievement, he lost control over his spiritual energy and fell off the sword again.

"Don't worry, Brother Yuan, you'll get used to it." Xiao Hua encouraged him.

Thus, Yuan began training with this flying sword for the remainder of the day.

After many hours of training, Yuan was finally able to remain standing on the sword even when it was flying at 100 miles per hour. However, any faster than that and he would fall right off the sword.

By the end of the day, Yuan could finally withstand the flying sword traveling over 300 miles per hour. Of course, he still needed Xiao Hua to control the sword for him.

"Okay, Xiao Hua, it's about time for me to log off. We can start traveling to the Purple Bamboo Forest after I return." Yuan said to her at the end.

"Un." Xiao Hua nodded before returning to the necklace, and Yuan logged off shortly later.

After logging off, Yuan could already hear the sound of gentle footsteps approaching his room, and he immediately knew it was Yu Rou.

Once the door to his room opened, Yu Rou's soft voice resounded, "I apologize for not being able to take care of you yesterday, Brother."

"There's no need for you to apologize. Even you need to rest on some days. Anyway, are you okay? I heard from the maid that you were speaking with Father and Mother." Yuan said to her.

"Haha..." A low-spirited laugh escaped from Yu Rou's mouth, and she spoke, "Instead of speaking, it was more like being scolded."

"Eh? You were scolded? Now that's something you won't hear every day. What did you do?" Yuan was surprised to learn that Yu Rou had been scolded, as she was the role model type of girl who's always respectful and obedient towards her parents.

"Well, my grades in school dropped a little bit— enough for me to get scolded."

Although Yuan couldn't see her expression, he could hear the bitterness in her voice.

"I see... Our parents are very strict when it comes to performance, after all..." Yuan said.

"They can be too strict at times..." she sighed.

"Anyway, let's not talk about such a depressing subject. Why don't you tell me about your experience with Cultivation Online while I help you clean? How are you enjoying the game so far?" Yu Rou asked him a moment later.

"To say I am enjoying it is an understatement!" Yuan quickly said.

"Oh? Tell me more about it." Yu Rou smiled after hearing his voice that was filled with excitement and happiness, which was an unfamiliar feeling even for her.

Chapter 39 - Player Killing

"Just the other day, for the first time in many years, I got to eat something that's not soup or porridge!" Yuan recalled to Yu Rou the wonderful food he'd eaten in the game. "Even though I'd spent all of my money on it, I do not regret it!"

"And let me tell you— eating food in the game feels no different than eating in real life! You can taste every flavor and spice in the food! I don't know how they did it, but this kind of technology is simply otherworldly!"

"Is that all you've been doing in the game? Eating food?" Yu Rou chuckled at him. "What about your cultivation? Isn't that the main focus of the game? How far have you progressed?"

"I don't know how I am doing compared to the others, but I think I am progressing at a steady pace."

Hearing his words, Yu Rou said, "Most of the top players around the world are just reaching the ninth level Spirit Apprentice Realm. What level are you, Brother?"

'What? They are just reaching the ninth level? Why are they so slow? Does this make me a top player?' Yuan pondered to himself.

"Uhh... I am at the fourth level..." Yuan said a moment later, purposefully leaving out the 'Spirit Warrior Realm' so he can surprise her later on.

"The fourth level only?! Just how much have you been slacking, Brother? At this rate, I will catch up to you even though I am a week late to the game!"

"Does one's cultivation really matter? It's not as though you cannot play the game without cultivating..." Yuan said to her, unable to comprehend why everyone is trying so hard to improve their cultivation.

"And I feel like cultivating normally takes too much time, and it's too boring since you only sit there and breathe."

"While it's true that you do not need to cultivate to play the game, you are going to get bullied by other players and even NPCs if you are not strong in the game. The saying 'only the strong survives' is deeply rooted in the game's world and it's almost like nature itself there, so if you are not strong enough, you won't be able to survive, much less enjoy the game."

"There are even many players who are killing other players to loot their items, and Player Killing is getting more popular by the day." Yu Rou said to him.

"Ah? Player Killing? What a pain in the ass..." Yuan shook his head inwardly. Now he not only has to deal with psychopathic NPCs who will kill you if you even slightly bother them but also other players?

"Why can't everyone just enjoy the game peacefully? Why must they dirty such a beautiful world with blood and corpses?"

"It's the nature of the game so there's nothing we can do about it. Even if you try to mind your own business and not cause trouble for others, other players will still cause trouble for you. And if it's not a player, it'll be an NPC. That's why you should cultivate seriously if you wish to enjoy the game, Brother. I don't want to see anyone bullying you."

Hearing her concerned voice, Yuan spoke with a smile on his face, "Don't worry, Yu Rou. I won't let anyone bully me, nor will I let anyone bully you in the game. If they cause even the slightest trouble for you, your brother here will cut them down without mercy."

Yu Rou chuckled at his words and said, "Before you start cutting anyone, you should start improving your cultivation first."

"Then I shall raise my cultivation just for you, Yu Rou," Yuan said.

Sometime later, after Yu Rou finished cleaning and feeding Yuan, she asked him, "Do you have anything else you want to say before I leave?"

"Yeah, just one thing." Yuan said, and he took a deep breath before continuing, "Thank you, and good night."

"Good night, Brother. I can't wait to play with you in a few days." Yu Rou said to him before leaving the room.

After Yu Rou left the room, Yuan went to sleep shortly later.

Meanwhile, inside her own room, Yu Rou surfed the internet for the latest Cultivation Online news.

"Hmm? Player Yuan makes the headlines again? He sure is popular, even having his own forums." Yu Rou clicked on the link without even thinking and began reading the forums that only had posts about Player Yuan.

[Player Yuan has become the first player to accumulate over 1,000,000 gold coins in Cultivation Online, which is worth over 10,000,000 dollars at the current market rates!]

[Player Yuan is currently the only player on the Wealth Leaderboards!]

[Player Yuan becomes the first person to slay a Demonic Spider!]

[Player Yuan managed to solo the dungeon 'Demonic Spider's Silent Cave', even achieving the First Clear!]

[Just who is this Player Yuan?! Click here to find out!]

[Top 10 theories on Player Yuan and his real identity!]

[Another player claiming to be Player Yuan has appeared!]

There were over a hundred topics on Player Yuan on the forums, and it would take Yu Rou the entire night if she wanted to read through all of

them.

"This Player Yuan's reputation is growing by the day— to the point where there are already people impersonating him. The questions people have about his existence are almost countless. It would be interesting if I could somehow meet this player in the game."

After spending an hour on the internet, Yu Rou entered her bed and went to sleep.

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Chapter 40 - Contemp

Early in the morning, before the sun was even out, the alarm beside Yu Rou rang, waking her from her slumber.

After waking up and tidying her bed, Yu Rou went to the bathroom to take a quick shower, wash her face, and brush her hair, before going to the kitchen to cook breakfast. However, she was not feeding herself.

Once breakfast was finished, Yu Rou carried the bowl of soup she'd just cooked and some other things to a large room that was isolated at the end of the hall.

"Brother, are you awake?" Yu Rou knocked on the door before going into the room.

"I'm awake," Yuan spoke in a hoarse voice.

"Let me brush your teeth."

Yu Rou proceeded to lift Yuan into a sitting position before brushing his teeth and wiping his face with a warm towel.

A few minutes later, she began feeding him the soup she'd personally cooked.

"How's the temperature?" she asked him.

"Perfect."

Yu Rou wore a smile on her face as she continued feeding him a spoon at a time.

"Brother, my four-day vacation from school starts in three days, so I will finally be able to play with you soon." Yu Rou said to him.

"That's great... I want you to meet a friend I've made in the game. She reminds me of you a lot..." Yuan said with a smile on her face.

"She...?" A slight frown appeared on Yu Rou's face when she learned that Yuan made a female friend.

"Is she pretty?" she decided to ask him.

"Yeah, she's very cute. I'm sure that you'll get along with her easily." Yuan said without hesitation.

Yu Rou's eyebrows trembled at his words, and she said, "I highly doubt that, Brother."

"Why not? She's already like a second sister to me."

"Second sister?!" Yu Rou exclaimed in a surprised voice, and she quickly said, "I hope you are not getting fooled by her, Brother. You are not very experienced with that kind of stuff, after all."

Yu Rou was worried that Yuan might've been tricked by some sly fox with unkind intentions, as these kinds of people were a dime a dozen these days.

"Listen here, Brother. You may not know this but there are many people out there who will willingly pretend to be your friends for their personal benefits, and once they have what they wanted from you, they will toss you aside like trash! Even though it's just a game, you must stay vigilant, especially with the females! They are the craftiest ones! Who knows what kind of trouble you'll get into with them..." Yu Rou gave him a stern warning.

"Haha... you are overexaggerating..." Yuan chuckled at her words, and he said, "Xiao Hua is not that kind of person. You'll understand it once you meet her."

"Don't worry, Brother, that will be the first thing I do once I can play the game!"

After chatting for a few more minutes, Yu Rou said, "Brother, it's time for me to go. I'll see you again later tonight."

"Have a safe day," Yuan said to her before entering the game.

Once Yu Rou left Yuan's room, she went to eat breakfast that was prepared by someone else.

"Young Lady, for breakfast we have..."

A middle-aged lady wearing maid clothes began explaining the food on the table for Yu Rou.

After Yu Rou finished eating breakfast, the maid said to her, "The car is ready, Young Lady."

Yu Rou gracefully wiped her lips with a napkin before nodding her head.

Sometime later, Yu Rou was escorted outside by another maid.

"Haaa... why must the Young Lady waste her precious time on that cripple? I even heard that her performance in school was lower than usual. She must not be getting enough sleep because of that cripple." One of the maids sighed in a pained tone after Yu Rou was gone.

"There's nothing we can do about it. The Young Lady insists on taking care of him by herself, even restricting us from going into his room without her permission," said another maid.

"Why does she care so much for him? I doubt he is able to do anything for her with that useless body."

"I have only heard of this from the older servants, but apparently the Young Master used to have a healthy body."

"Does it really matter what happened in the past? The fact is that he's a cripple now and will continue to be one in the future. I simply cannot fathom the Young Lady's thoughts. She could easily gather countless men with her status and beauty, yet she'd rather spend her time with a bed stricken cripple who might die at any moment."

"You should really watch your mouth. If the Young Lady hears such words, losing your job will be the least of your worries..."

While the maids in the house talked behind Yuan's back, Yuan was having the time of his life soaring besides the clouds in the sky on a flying sword.

"WOOOHOOOO~~! This is the best feeling ever!" Yuan shouted from excitement as he flew over mountains and rivers, feeling as free as a bird.

"Be careful, Brother Yuan. You'll fall if you lose control of your spiritual energy." Xiao Hua warned him from behind. And unlike Yuan, who needed the assistance of the flying sword to fly, she was flying in the air with just her spiritual energy alone.

"I don't understand why anyone would walk if they can just ride these things. If I could fly, I'd be flying everywhere— even in the streets!"

"Flying gets tiring if you do it for too long, and it consumes too much spiritual energy. Most people would rather save as much spiritual energy as they can in case they run into trouble. And because not many people have reached the Spirit Grandmaster level in this place, we will barely run into any Cultivators who can fly." Xiao Hua explained to him.

"I see... Anyway, how long before we reach our destination?" Yuan asked her.

"We will arrive in a few hours. But we'll also take short breaks in-between because Brother Yuan cannot remain on the sword for long."

"Sounds good." Yuan nodded.

Chapter 41 - Pang City

After flying for a little under an hour, Yuan was beginning to feel fatigued from using his spiritual energy constantly.

'How am I feeling tired already?! I have over 100 million Qi!' Yuan was baffled by how quickly his Qi depleted when he had over 100 million Qi.

Either flying requires a massive amount of Qi to maintain or the large number of Qi does not justify his actual amount of Qi.

'No wonder why Cultivators rather walk than fly!' He sighed inwardly.

"Hold on a little bit longer, Brother Yuan." Xiao Hua suddenly said to him. "There's a small city up ahead. We can rest there."

A few minutes later, Yuan could see the city walls with buildings inside a few miles in the distance. Although it did not appear to be as big as Spirit City, it was still considerably spacious.

«You have discovered 'Pang City'»

Sometime later, Yuan and Xiao Hua descended from the sky and landed near the city entrance, instantly attracting the attention of everyone there.

"An expert! It's an expert!"

"I have never seen anyone fly without the assistance of a flying sword before!"

The people there began mumbling to each other with awe, their gazes filled with respect.

When the guards at the gates saw Yuan and Xiao Hua, they immediately approached them and bowed to them, "Welcome to Pang City, Seniors!"

"Seniors?" Yuan raised his eyebrows in a baffled manner. Does he really look that old in the eyes of these guards?

"Listen here, I am only 18 years old. Don't address me as if I am an old man... That's disrespectful." Yuan said to them.

"..."

The guards stared at Yuan with even larger eyes after hearing his words. What kind of prodigy could control a flying sword at such a young age?! Calling him a genius would still be an understatement!

"O-Our apologies, Young Master!"

The guards apologized when they snapped out of their daze.

"Brother Yuan, people care about your power above anything else in the Cultivation world. Being called a Senior means they acknowledge that your strength is above theirs, and it's not disrespectful at all."

"Is that so? But it still feels weird to be addressed in such a manner." Yuan said.

"Anyway, what do you want with us?" He asked the guards a moment later.

"If it's not too much to ask, we would like to know the Young Master and Young Lady's reason for visiting this place." The guards responded still with their heads lowered.

"We don't have any reason, really. We're only taking a break here before we resume our journey." Yuan said to them.

"If the Young Masters are looking for a place to rest, may we recommend the Lord's Manor," said one of the guards.

"The Lord's Manor? That sounds like a very expensive place, and we won't be staying here for long, so it's not necessary." Yuan quickly rejected their offer, as he was personally penniless.

"Don't worry about the expenses, Young Master. The Lord won't charge you even a single coin." The guards said to him.

"But I don't want to intrude on this person without any reason," Yuan said. In his eyes, it was simply too awkward for him to stay in someone's house without any good reason, not to mention a place as impressive-sounding as the 'Lord's Manor'.

"To tell you the truth, we are only following the Lord's orders, as he is currently in a troubled situation and is looking for experts for help." The guards suddenly revealed the real reason why they wanted him to go to the Lord's Manor.

"Oh?" Yuan's eyes flickered with interest upon hearing the guards' words.

'Could this be a quest? Maybe the real reason they approached me is because I am a player...' Yuan thought to himself.

"I guess it won't hurt to visit this person who might need our help. What do you think, Xiao Hua?" Yuan nodded a moment later.

"Xiao Hua will follow Brother Yuan's decision," she quickly responded.

"Okay, then let's go to this Lord's Manor," Yuan said to the guards, who immediately wore very bright smiles on their faces.

"Thank you very much, Young Masters! The Lord will be filled with joy once he learns of this!"

"Please wait a moment while I find an escort for the Young Masters!"

One of the guards quickly left the scene.

A few minutes later, the guard returned with a very beautiful lady who did not have the appearance of an ordinary escort.

"Welcome to Pang City, esteemed guests." The lady greeted them with courtesy before introducing herself, "I am Luo Ling, the eldest daughter of the Luo Family that governs this humble city. Allow me to escort you back to my home."

"You can call me Yuan, and this is Xiao Hua." Yuan gave her a quick introduction.

"Senior Yuan and Senior Xiao, right?"

"You can drop the formality and just call me Yuan." He said to her, as it felt incredibly weird for a beautiful lady who only appeared to be in her mid-twenties to call him 'Senior'.

"How does Daoist Yuan sound? I do not dare to address someone as powerful as you so casually." Luo Ling said to him.

"Powerful...? You are giving me too much credit. I am only at the Spirit Warrior level." Yuan said with a bashful smile.

"Despite that, you emit a very formidable aura, not to mention the Young Lady beside you..." Luo Ling looked at Xiao Hua with a nervous gaze.

Although she cannot see Xiao Hua's entire cultivation base, she was certain that Xiao Hua was at least at the Spirit Grandmaster level, as many people here have witnessed her flying without the assistance of a flying sword, and she even emits the aura of a true expert.

"Daoist Yuan is fine, I guess." He nodded a moment later.

Luo Ling proceeded to escort Yuan and Xiao Hua into the city.

Meanwhile, the people that had to wait in line to get inside the Pang City began mumbling to each other.

"Did you see that? I have never seen Lady Luo personally receive guests before!"

"Of course I saw it! I am not blind! And those two were clearly experts! It'd only be obvious that they would be treated with the utmost respect!"

"Hey... did you hear that young man just now? I think he called himself 'Yuan'..."

"Could he be the Player Yuan that everyone and their mother has been talking about?"

"Are you sure you heard right? He didn't give off the feeling of a Player, much less an unfathomable individual such as Player Yuan. He's probably just an NPC with a similar name."

"Yeah, probably."

"It would be amazing if he was the real Player Yuan, though."

A group of players within the line chatted with each other while they waited for their turn to enter the city.

Chapter 42 - Luo Family

After entering the city, Yuan said to Luo Ling, "The guards mentioned that the Lord of this city is currently in a troubled situation. What's troubling him, and how can we help him?"

"Well, it's like this, Daoist Yuan. A few days ago, some ignorant adventurer went into the mountains to hunt, and he accidentally killed the Mountain Lord's child. This greatly angered the Mountain Lord, who immediately blamed our city and swore to send an army of monsters to trample us very soon."

"Mountain Lord? Is that a person or...?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"The Mountain Lord is a fearsome beast at the fifth level of the Spirit Warrior realm, and it is a guardian of sorts for the Pang Mountain that's right beside our Pang City. If it attacks our city, only my father who's also at the fifth level of the Spirit Warrior realm can fight it, but then he won't be able to protect the city against the other monsters, and we are currently lacking in manpower with around 50 guards with most of them being at the Spirit Apprentice level." Luo Ling explained the situation to him.

"This is why we are looking for any help we can get. If Daoist Yuan is willing to lend us your power, it would definitely help us a lot, and we won't spare any effort into repaying you afterward." Luo Ling said to him with her head lowered.

"Since this city needs help and the strongest threat is only at the fifth level of the Spirit Warrior realm, there's no reason why I would refuse to give you my assistance." Yuan nodded.

Now that he is at the fourth level of the Spirit Warrior realm, he shouldn't have any problems fighting even seventh level Spirit Warriors, much less a Spirit Warrior at the fifth level.

"Thank you very much, Daoist Yuan! My father will definitely be ecstatic to hear this later!" Luo Ling bowed to him again before they continued walking.

Sometime later, they arrived at a massive building that was situated in the middle of the city.

"Welcome to my family's humble home." Luo Ling said to him when they were at the front gates.

"..."

Yuan looked at the decorated building with wide eyes. How can such a place be described as 'humble'?

"Welcome back, Young Lady. Welcome to the Lord's Manor, esteemed guests." The guards by the gate greeted them when they approached.

"Where's my father?" she asked them.

"Lord Luo should be finishing up with the other guests right as we speak—"

"Oh! Esteemed guests! You are finally here!"

A middle-aged man wearing luxurious official clothes suddenly came running out of the building in the middle of the guard's sentence.

"Welcome to my humble home, esteemed guests! The guards have already briefed me about your presence. Thank you so much for taking the time to even listen to our request despite being so busy yourselves." Lord Luo extended his hands to Yuan for a handshake.

"Don't worry about it. We are not actually that busy, anyway." Yuan said as he accepted Lord Luo's handshake.

"Please, let us continue speaking inside."

Lord Luo then led them into a large guest room and said to Luo Ling, "Bring us our finest tea, and bring the other two here while you're at it."

"Yes, father." Luo Ling nodded.

"Excuse me for a moment, Daoist Yuan." She said to him before leaving the room.

"Esteemed guests, once again, allow me to thank you for coming here." Lord Luo said to them a moment later.

"Just call me Daoist Yuan, and I have heard everything about your situation from Luo Ling," Yuan said to him. "You need help defending the city, right?"

"That's right, Daoist Yuan. As shameful as it may sound, being only a fifth level Spirit Warrior, I do not have what it takes to defend the city in this dire situation. We usually don't have to worry about the beasts within the Pang Mountain because of a peace treaty between the city and the Mountain Lord, but because of what happened with the Mountain Lord's child, the treaty was broken. We had even tried to bring the perpetrator directly to the Mountain Lord, hoping it'd at least spare the innocent people in the city, but alas, the Mountain Lord was too consumed in anger to even care." Lord Luo spoke in a sighing voice.

"Daoist Yuan, the city and I will be eternally grateful even if you can help us take care of the weaker monsters, as it's the people in the city that I am the most worried about, and I will handle the Mountain Lord by myself."

«You have received a Quest»

«Quest: Protecting Pang City»

«Difficulty: Easy»

«Quest Description: Defend the Pang City against the Mountain Lord's attack»

Yuan nodded his head and said, "Okay, we'll help you defend the city."

"Thank you! Thank you very much, Daoist Yuan!"

Sometime later, Luo Ling returned to the room with a teapot and two cups along with two other individuals that appeared to be around the same age as Yuan.

"Let me introduce you to my other children, Daoist Yuan." Lord Luo pointed at the handsome young man and said, "This is my eldest son Luo Ming, who is 20 years old and at the first level Spirit Warrior."

"Hello, fellow Daoist." Luo Ming nodded at him.

Lord Luo then moved to the beautiful young lady beside him and said, "This is my youngest child, Luo Li, who is at the same age as Daoist Yuan and at the peak of the Spirit Apprentice level."

"It's a pleasure to meet someone as talented and handsome as Daoist Yuan." She gave him a graceful bow with the colors on her cheeks slightly rosy.

'Handsome...?' Yuan raised his eyebrows. This is the first time anyone's ever praised him for being handsome.

'Now that I think about it, I don't know what my appearance looks like in this game...' Yuan suddenly came to this realization, as he never really cared about his own appearance, hence why he did not give it any thoughts until now.

Chapter 43 - Ulterior Motives

After his children introduced themselves, Lord Luo said to Yuan, "Daoist Yuan, you came to the Pang City to rest, right? I have already arranged two of our best rooms for you and the Young Lady. And from the information we've gathered, the Mountain Lord plans on attacking us either tomorrow or the day after, so you are free to do whatever you want until then."

"I will leave one of my children with you just in case you need anything." Lord Luo then turned to look at his youngest daughter, Luo Li with a sharp gaze.

Luo Li immediately realized what her father was trying to tell her and stepped forward.

"I will be taking care of all of your needs, Daoist Yuan. If there's anything you desire, don't hesitate to talk to me," she said to him.

Assisting the guests' needs are usually the servants' job, but Lord Luo specifically assigned his own daughter to take care of Yuan simply because he hoped that some kind of romantic relationship could bud between them, as it would definitely benefit their family to have a talented individual like Yuan with them.

"I'll be troubling you," Yuan calmly said, unable to take the obvious hint.

"Luo Li, show the guests their rooms. I have to return to the other guests since I kind of left them hanging to come here." Lord Luo said to her.

He then turned to look at Yuan and said, "I won't bother you any longer, Daoist Yuan. If you need anything — anything at all — just let my daughter know and she'll take care of it. Although she may be young, I can proudly say that I've raised a very competent daughter."

After Lord Luo and the others left the room, Luo Li said to Yuan, "Shall we head to your room now?"

Yuan nodded and followed her to a large room somewhere down the hall.

"This will be Daoist Yuan's room, and the one next to it will be the Young Lady's room." Luo Li said to them.

"Xiao Hua will stay with Brother Yuan." Xiao Hua suddenly said to her.

"That's okay, too. The bed is large enough to fit four people, after all." Luo Li nodded.

A few moments later, when they entered the room, Yuan was amazed by the spacious room that was decorated with Chinese antiques in almost every direction.

"What do you think, Daoist Yuan? Is this room to your taste?" Luo Li asked him a moment later.

"Un." He quickly nodded.

"Then I will leave you alone for now. If you need anything, I will be standing outside." Luo Li said to him.

"Eh? You don't have to do that. It would actually have the opposite effect, and I won't be able to relax." Yuan looked at her with wide eyes.

"Then what do you suggest, Daoist Yuan? My father told me to stay with you, after all. He won't like it if I left you alone."

Yuan scratched his head before saying, "I guess you can stay here for now. I have a few questions about a few things, too."

"Then I shall stay in this room with Daoist Yuan." Luo Li nodded before walking to the door and standing there like a guardian of sorts.

"You don't have to be so strict with yourself. Sit down and relax." Yuan said to her with a weird smile on his face, feeling kind of awkward with her

seriousness.

Sometime later, Yuan and Luo Li sat across each other on the couch.

"Your father mentioned other guests. Are they also going to be helping with defending the city?" Yuan asked her.

"Yes. Most of them are warriors who came from a very distant land, and they were all very eager to help us defend the city after we told them about our situation, and we cannot be more thankful to everyone for helping us, especially you, Daoist Yuan." Luo Li said with a beautiful smile on her face.

'A distant land? Could they be players like myself?' Yuan thought to himself.

"I see... then can you tell me more about this place?" he asked a moment later.

"Our Pang City? We're just an ordinary city with a few thousand citizens. Compared to Daoist Yuan's background, we're not even worth mentioning." Luo Li replied with an embarrassed smile.

"My background?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

Luo Li nodded and said, "Despite being the same age as me, Daoist Yuan is already at the fourth level Spirit Warrior. I have never met anyone as talented as you before. Surely, you must come from a powerful sect or a renowned family."

However, Yuan quickly shook his head and said, "I'm neither from a powerful sect or a renowned family."

"Eh? Really? Then where did Daoist Yuan come from? And who taught you how to Cultivate?" Luo Li looked at him with wide eyes, as she cannot imagine someone as talented as Yuan coming from nowhere.

"Well, I am also from a distant land that is not well-known in this place. As for who taught me cultivation..." Yuan turned to look at Xiao Hua, who was

casually sitting beside him with a calm expression.

"This Young Lady taught you cultivation?" Luo Li stared at her with a dazed expression.

However, Xiao Hua shook her head and said, "Xiao Hua did not really do anything. It was Brother Yuan who learned everything by himself."

"That's not true, Xiao Hua. If not for you I would not have become a Cultivator so soon, and you were the one who gave me the cultivation technique and taught me what it means to be a Cultivator."

"Xiao Hua merely gave Brother Yuan the chance to learn the cultivation technique. It was mostly due to Brother Yuan's own effort and talent that he managed to learn it."

Luo Li was speechless. Hearing their conversation, it sounded as if Yuan had only become a Cultivator very recently.

"When did Daoist Yuan start cultivating?" she decided to ask him out of curiosity.

"Uhh... about a week ago?" Yuan said after pondering for a bit.

"..."

Luo Li stared at him with wide eyes that were filled with disbelief. It'd taken him only a week to reach the fourth level Spirit Warrior realm from the beginning? What kind of cultivation monster is he?!

Chapter 44 - Appearance

"Don't think too much about it, you'll only give yourself a headache," Xiao Hua suddenly said to Luo Li, almost as though she could read her mind. "Brother Yuan is a prodigy that appears once every few generations. You won't understand his talent with ordinary logic."

"Is...Is that so...?" Luo Li decided to take Xiao Hua's advice and stopped thinking about it.

Sometime later, Yuan said, "By the way, I would like to take a look around this city if you don't mind."

"Of course not! Let me speak with my father first, then I will guide you around the city!" Luo Li quickly said.

Yuan nodded, and Luo Li left the room shortly later.

Once Luo Li was gone, Yuan looked around the room with curiosity, as this is his first time being inside such a unique room, and that is when he noticed the tall mirror sitting at the corner of the room.

"Oh? A mirror?" Yuan immediately stood up and walked to the mirror with his heart filled with anticipation and nervousness. What does he look like in this world? Is he really as handsome as Luo Li described him?

"This is me...?"

Yuan stood before the mirror that was slightly taller than his head with a dazed face.

He had short but silky black hair on his oval-shaped head, clear brown eyes that were bright as crystals, long eyelashes that would make even females

jealous, sharp but neat eyebrows, and a small nose. Overall, his face was very symmetrical and pleasant-looking.

The last time he'd seen his own face was when he was 7 years old— before he lost his ability to see and became blind.

"If I recall correctly, Yu Rou once mentioned that one's appearance in the game will closely resemble their appearance in the real world, hence why I entered this game with an avatar already created for me. However, I do not know what I look like in the real world, and it has been over 10 years since I last saw my own face, so I cannot confirm whether this face really resembles my real appearance or not..."

Furthermore, because he does not know the standard regarding one's appearance, he cannot really tell whether he's really handsome or not.

Therefore, he decided to ask someone else for their opinion.

"Xiao Hua, I have a question for you." Yuan suddenly said to her.

"What is it, Brother Yuan?"

He then pointed at his own face and asked with a serious expression, "Without being biased, what do you think of my appearance? Would you say that I am handsome? Or am I ugly?"

"..."

Xiao Hua looked at him with wide eyes, seemingly speechless by his sudden question.

A few moments later, she spoke in a bashful voice and with slightly rosy cheeks, "Xiao Hua thinks Brother Yuan is very handsome..."

"Really? Are you sure that you're not just complimenting me because you don't want to hurt my feelings? It's okay to tell the truth, Xiao Hua." Yuan said to her, as he had a feeling that her judgment might be somewhat inaccurate because of their relationship.

"X-Xiao Hua is telling the truth! Brother Yuan is very handsome!" Xiao Hua said again, but her face was flushed with redness this time.

"Okay, I will trust your judgment." Yuan nodded.

"..."

Xiao Hua was speechless. Why would he even want this kind of feedback? Did he not look in the mirror just now? Anyone with a working brain would agree that Yuan was handsome. Or did he just want to tease her?

"Why are you asking about your appearance, Brother Yuan? Is it because of that Luo girl?" she decided to ask him.

However, Yuan quickly shook his head and said, "No, I was just wondering because I have never really cared for my own appearance."

"Don't worry, Brother Yuan. In the cultivation world, one's appearance isn't that important. As long as you are talented and powerful, unless you have the world's ugliest face, you'll be able to attract girls! And since Brother Yuan is both talented and handsome, you will, without doubt, have beauties fighting for you in every direction in the future!" Thinking that Yuan was worried about his appearance, Xiao Hua decided to cheer him up.

"Hahaha... My appearance is the least of my worries, Xiao Hua..." Yuan laughed in a bitter voice.

A few minutes later, Luo Li returned to the room. However, she looked a little bit different than before she left, almost as though she came back even prettier.

It was obvious that besides speaking with her father, Luo Li had spent some time improving her own appearance with light makeup.

Of course, as someone who doesn't pay much attention to appearances, Yuan was completely oblivious of this fact.

"Daoist Yuan, I have let my father know about your wishes to look around the city. We can leave whenever you want," she said to him.

"Okay, then let's leave now," Yuan said.

Sometime later, they left the Lord's Manor.

"Where do you wish to visit first, Daoist Yuan?" she asked him once they were outside.

Yuan shrugged and said, "I don't know what's in this city, so I'll let you choose where to visit."

However, as this is her first time giving a tour to someone, Luo Li was also unsure of where to go. Therefore, she decided to just walk around the city until they come across something that would pique Yuan's interest.

"That fruit stall over there is managed by Madam Ying, and it always has the freshest fruits in the city."

"That's Mister Wang's Treasure, the only weapon shop in our city."

"This is the residences' area, where most of the citizens live."

"That building over there is Li's Clinic..."

Luo Li gave a brief explanation for most of the shops and buildings they passed, and Yuan would listen to her with a bright face, looking as though he was in an amusement park.

However, he would show the most interest when Luo Li talked about the buildings that were related to food, and upon noticing this, Luo Li asked him, "Would you like to experience some of Pang City's finest cuisines?"

"Really?" Yuan immediately became excited. But when he remembered that his wallet was near empty, he asked her, "I only have ten gold coins on me. Will that be enough?"

Finding his question quite silly, Luo Li couldn't help but laugh slightly, "With 10 gold coins, you can eat everything on every single menu in this city and still have plenty of money left."

"What? The food here is that cheap? My last meal was atrociously expensive in comparison!" Yuan was shocked to learn that the food in this place was so cheap, especially when he'd spent 500 gold coins on his previous meal.

"Brother Yuan, that's because you were stuffing your face with expensive spiritual meat... Normal food will only cost a few silver coins at most." Xiao Hua said to him.

"Is that so? Then what are we waiting for? Let's go eat until our stomachs are round!" Yuan quickly said.

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Chapter 45 - Bounty

Sometime later, Luo Li brought Yuan to one of their largest and most famous restaurants.

"Hundred Style Pork Shop?" Yuan looked at the sign above the door with a slightly wet mouth.

"As the name implies, this restaurant specializes in pork. Of course, there are other foods on the menu, but they are most famous for their pork." Luo Li said to them before they walked inside.

"Welcome to the Hundred Style Pork Shop, Lady Luo!" The receptionist immediately recognized and greeted Luo Li.

"Table for three," she said.

"I understand. Please, come with me."

The receptionist then led them to the largest table in the room that could easily fit even a large family.

"Here's the menu, Young Lady."

"Thank you. By the way, you can send the bill to my family." Luo Li then said to the receptionist.

"Eh? Are you sure?" Yuan asked her when he heard her words.

"Yes. Although it's not much, please allow my family to treat Daoist Yuan to this meal. If my father was here, he would've also said the same. After all, Daoist Yuan is still our esteemed guest. If we cannot even do something

as simple as feeding you, then it would bring shame upon the entire Luo Family." Luo Li said.

"You're exaggerating..." Yuan said with an awkward smile, as he was not used to this royalty-like treatment.

"Anyway, please order whatever you want, Daoist Yuan. My family will bear all of your bills today."

Seeing the stubbornly beautiful smile on Luo Li's face, Yuan could only nod his head and accept her offer.

A few moments later, Yuan began ordering from the menu.

"I'll have this braised pork, this seasoned pork, this pulled pork, this... this... this... and this..."

"..."

Both the receptionist and Luo Li stared at Yuan with wide eyes as he continued to name dishes after dishes until he named almost every dish that was available on the menu.

Meanwhile, Xiao Hua casually sat there with a calm expression, looking as though she was used to seeing this scene.

"V-Very well. I'll immediately notify the cooks..." The receptionist quickly left their table a few minutes later with her hands feeling slightly numb from writing essentially the entire menu.

"D-Daoist Yuan must have been starving from his journey..." Luo Li said to him with a stiff smile on her face, while silently wondering to herself whether Yuan really had the ability to eat so much food.

"Yes, I am quite exhausted after riding the flying sword for so long." Yuan nodded.

"If you don't mind me asking, where does Daoist Yuan plan on heading to after the Pang City?" she suddenly asked him.

"Oh, we are heading to the Purple Bamboo Forest for training," he said with a calm expression.

"The Purple Bamboo Forest?!" Luo Li covered her mouth in shock after hearing his words.

"Eh? What's the matter?" Yuan was surprised by her reaction.

"The Purple Bamboo Forest is renowned for nurturing powerful beasts above the Spirit Warrior realm! It's a dangerous place where beasts as powerful as the Mountain Lord are abundant, and only the strongest warriors would dare to train such a place!" Luo Li looked at Yuan with awe in her eyes, "To think Daoist Yuan would go to such a dangerous place just for training, you are truly on another level compared to me, who cannot even go to the Pang Mountain without supervision. I am now feeling ashamed to even share the same table as you..."

"It may be a dangerous place, but how else am I going to grow stronger?" Yuan laughed.

"Indeed, while it may be dangerous, the cultivation world is already filled with danger, and only those who are willing to risk their lives for improvements like Daoist Yuan can truly reach the peak. I really admire Daoist Yuan for that." Luo Li said to him with an adoring gaze.

Sometime later, the receptionist and a few servers returned to their table with dishes in both their hands.

"We will continue bringing the dishes as they are being cooked. Do you need another table to hold the dishes?" The servers asked them.

"No, it's fine. Brother Yuan will finish the dishes before you can even bring out new plates..." Xiao Hua said to them.

Sometime later, once the table was filled with dishes, Yuan quickly began stuffing his face with food.

"Oh, man! This food is really amazing! The meat is so flavorful and filled with juices! Every bite I take fills my mouth with bliss!"

"..."

Luo Li watched as Yuan constantly shove food into his mouth without stopping with a dazed face, silently wondering to herself, 'Daoist Yuan is truly unfathomable... How can so much food fit into that body?'

A few moments later, Luo Li also began eating the food, but unlike Yuan, she ate as slow and as gracefully as possible, as she was afraid of ruining her makeup.

And just like Xiao Hua had predicted, Yuan managed to finish the dishes on the table before the next round of plates were brought to them, which greatly shocked the servers there.

"Hey, did you hear? They increased their offer for Player Yuan again."

Suddenly, as he was chewing his food, Yuan heard the people sitting behind them mention his name, causing him to slow down.

"I saw it. It's up to 50 million dollars, right?"

"They are even awarding anyone who can identify Player Yuan with 5 million."

"5 million?! I will be set for life with that amount of money!"

"It will only be a matter of time before one of his friends or even family members reveal his real identity to the world for the money."

"I can't believe people are willing to pay that much money for a cheater like Player Yuan."

"You will never understand the rich."

"There are even some people who want to see Player Yuan being PK'd! I think the bounty is around 10 million right now."

"Hahaha... Reward or not, if I ever see this Player Yuan, I'm definitely going to Player Kill him!"

"..."

Yuan slowly turned around to look at the group of people chatting loudly behind him with a dumbfounded expression, his round cheeks still filled with food. Surely, they must be talking about someone else with the same name as him, right? After all, he does not recall doing anything that would make other players hate him to the point of putting a bounty on his head! Hell, he hasn't even encountered any other players until now!

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Chapter 46 - Learning About The Situation

"What's the matter, Brother Yuan? Are you full already?" Xiao Hua asked him after noticing that he'd stopped eating the food.

"No... not yet..." Yuan quickly returned to stuffing food into his mouth, but his ears remained perked and focused on the group of players behind him, as he was curious about this 'Player Yuan' they were mentioning. Surely, they must be talking about someone else who has the same name as him, right? After all, it's not uncommon for people to have the same name in games nowadays, as they have removed the 'unrepeatable names' limit for most games these days, allowing players to have whatever name they want without the frustration of changing names because someone had already picked the name before them.

"Though, this Player Yuan sure is quite the mystery. Anyone with a working brain would not hide their existence when there's so much fame to their name. If he continues to hide his identity, people will eventually forget about him, wasting this massive opportunity to become famous."

"Do you think Player Yuan is actually someone within the Legacy?"

"That's not possible. Everyone in the Legacy has already announced their identity in the game to the world, and we know that it's not possible for one person to have two different characters in this game even if they buy two consoles."

"It doesn't matter who this Player Yuan is! As long as there's a bounty for his head, everyone will be aiming to PK him!"

'Good heavens, what on earth did this Player Yuan do to make the players so angry?' Yuan silently pondered to himself as he listened to the players talk.

A few minutes later, when Yuan could no longer contain his curiosity, he turned around and spoke to the players, "Excuse me, can you tell me more about this Player Yuan? What did he do to make the others want to Player Kill him?"

Hearing his question, the players looked at him with a weird expression.

"Hm? You don't know about Player Yuan? Have you not been on the internet lately? Even people who don't play the game know about him!" One of them said to them.

"Unfortunately, I haven't..." Yuan said with a bitter smile.

"Well, Player Yuan is a mysterious player who has been dominating the game with an impossibly fast progression recently, and there are even accusations of him being a cheater."

"A cheater?" Yuan's eyes widened with surprise. How does one even cheat in this game?

"Is that why people want to PK him? Because he's cheating?" He then asked.

"That's only one of many reasons why people want him dead. Well, the biggest reason is that they envy this Player Yuan, who is akin to a god-like existence in this game at this current moment."

"God-like existence?" Yuan expressed awe.

"Of course. He not only has a Divine-grade technique but also a Divine-grade servant! And it hasn't even been that long since the game launched! It's no wonder people are calling him a cheater! How else can you progress that fast?!"

"Eh...?" Yuan's eyes widened with shock after hearing such words. A Divine-grade technique and a Divine-grade servant?

He slowly turned to look at Xiao Hua and swallowed nervously. Surely, it must only be some kind of coincidence...

When the players saw Yuan's bewildered reaction, they all laughed loudly, "Hahaha! We know exactly how you feel, young man! We also felt the same when we first heard it!"

"However, this Player Yuan is not only powerful, but he's also incredibly rich, as he'd obtained over 1,000,000 gold coins not long ago, becoming the first person to enter the Wealth Leaderboards!"

"And he even soloed this dungeon recently!"

"..."

Yuan began sweating profusely at their words.

'Heavens! They are really talking about me!' He cried inwardly after this realization.

"I-I see..." Yuan tried his best to remain calm and said to them, "Thank you for this information, I will now also keep my eyes out for this Player Yuan..."

"Good luck, buddy! We'll also try our best to find and kill this Player Yuan! But because almost every player is currently looking for him, it won't be that easy!" The players said to him with bright smiles all over their faces, and they left the restaurant shortly later.

"..."

Yuan quickly turned around and continued eating with his back soaked in cold sweat.

'What the hell?! I am definitely not a cheater! How dare people accuse me of cheating when they don't even know anything?!'

It was at this moment that Yuan swore to keep his identity a secret from the other players, as it would be disastrous if people knew of his real identity. And even if he was powerful enough to defeat other players, he did not want to fight every player that crosses paths with him in the future.

'Why have things become so complicated now? Why must I be hunted by every player in the world because I got a little bit lucky? I only want to enjoy this game like everyone else!' Yuan sighed inwardly.

However, this situation is something he cannot control, and he could only hope that people will soon forget about him.

Meanwhile, Xiao Hua and Luo Li silently stared at Yuan with a contemplating expression, almost as though they were unable to comprehend Yuan's conversation with the other players just now. However, they quickly gave up a few seconds later and continued eating as though it wasn't their concern.

An hour later, Yuan rubbed his round stomach with a satisfied expression. "Ahh, that was amazing..."

Luo Li chuckled and said to him, "What's even more amazing is Daoist Yuan's stomach. I did not think you would really eat everything, and I apologize for doubting your ability."

"Young Lady, the bill will be 6 gold coins..." The server said to her afterward.

"I will have someone bring the money over later," she nodded.

A few minutes later, all of the servers and even the cooks in the restaurant came outside to bow to them.

"We thank Young Lady and her friends for their patronage." They said to them.

"What should we do now, Daoist Yuan?" Luo Li asked him after they left the restaurant.

"Let's return to the Lord's Manor. I'm too full to do anything right now."
Yuan said to her.

"Very well." She nodded.

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Chapter 47 - Cultivation Technique Improvements

Upon returning to the Lord's Manor, Yuan went straight to his room with Xiao Hua, while Luo Li went to brief her father about their little tour and restaurant bill.

"What should we do now, Xiao Hua? We have plenty of time until the Mountain Lord attacks, but I don't want to just sit around and do nothing." Yuan said to her.

"Most people would cultivate during their free time, as every minute matters," she said to him.

"Eh... But I find cultivating normally very boring. I'm just sitting there and breathing, after all. And it'll take forever for me to reach the next level if I were to cultivate normally..." Yuan sighed.

Now that he needs millions upon millions of Qi to reach the next level, it would take him many days, even weeks to breakthrough a single level when his cultivation technique only absorbs 5 Qi per second.

"Cultivation, in general, takes a very long time," Xiao Hua said to him.

"Once Brother Yuan reaches the higher realms, it might take you decades of cultivation time to improve a single level."

"But since Brother Yuan doesn't want to cultivate normally, why don't Xiao Hua read her book for you?" Xiao Hua then suggested.

"Oh? That book?" Yuan nodded. Now that he's improved his cultivation, perhaps he might learn something new this time.

A few moments later, Xiao Hua retrieved her book and began reading it.

Yuan closed his eyes and focused on Xiao Hua's gentle and innocent voice.

Many minutes later, Luo Li returned to the room, but when she saw that Yuan had entered cultivation, she decided to remain outside until he was done, as it was very offensive to interrupt someone while they were cultivating, and it might even lead to internal injuries that are very difficult to heal.

A few hours later, Yuan opened his eyes, feeling as though new knowledge was gushing into his head.

«Your comprehension for Heaven's Secret Art has greatly increased»

«Heaven Consuming Technique Mastery Level (1) → (2)»

«Heaven Consuming Technique»

«Rank: Divine»

«Mastery Level: 2»

«Description: Absorbs 500 Qi every second. Can only be activated during cultivation in the lotus position»

«Heaven Splitting Sword Strike Mastery Level (1) → (2)»

«Heaven Splitting Sword Strike»

«Rank: Divine»

«Mastery Level: 2»

«Description: Consumes 10,000,000 Qi. Must wield a sword to activate. Creates a pillar of sword light that will destroy everything that dares to block its path»

'500 Qi per second! That's 100 times faster than before! And I need 10 million Qi to activate Heaven Splitting Sword Strike now?! That's 1,000 times more than before!' Yuan was shocked by the massive improvements to his cultivation technique.

'I guess it only makes sense that you would absorb and use more Qi the higher your level,' he thought to himself.

Seeing the formidable aura around Yuan, Xiao Hua could easily tell that he'd once again improved as a Cultivator.

'Just what is Brother Yuan's limit? Does he even have a limit to his talent?' Xiao Hua pondered to herself.

Every Cultivator under Heaven is either born with or without talent and for those born with talents, regardless of how much, there is always a limitation to their talents as set by the Mighty Heavens.

'No... There exist people who do not have a limit to their talents... but those people are...'

"Xiao Hua, my understanding of the cultivation technique has improved slightly," Yuan suddenly said to her. "I can now absorb more Qi with the cultivation technique."

Xiao Hua quickly tossed her thoughts to the side and said, "Brother Yuan is always improving so Xiao Hua is not surprised."

Meanwhile, when Luo Li heard the two of them talking, she knocked on the door and said, "Are you finished with cultivation, Daoist Yuan?"

"Eh? Don't tell me you have been standing outside this entire time?" Yuan quickly went to open the door for her.

"I did not want to bother Daoist Yuan, after all." She nodded.

"Anyway, I have some news for Daoist Yuan. We have new information on the Mountain Lord, and it might begin the invasion as early as tomorrow morning."

"I understand." He nodded.

"One more thing, my father would like to invite you for dinner later, but it's okay to refuse because we know that you might still be full from the restaurant earlier today."

"Dinner? That sounds great." Yuan immediately accepted their invitation regardless of how full his stomach was, as he would never turn down a meal as long as it wasn't only soup.

"That's great! I will let my father know." Luo Li said before disappearing again.

After Luo Li left, Yuan said to Xiao Hua, "I'm also going to leave for a bit. If she returns before I do, just let her know."

Xiao Hua nodded and watched as Yuan disappeared into thin air right before her eyes.

"..."

Silence filled the room after Yuan logged off, and Xiao Hua pondered with curiosity.

'How does Brother Yuan disappear and appear as he pleases like that? He shouldn't know any teleporting techniques. And where does he go?'

However, after pondering for a few seconds, almost as though something inside her head had flipped, Xiao Hua immediately lost all interest in Yuan's sudden disappearance and treated it as though it was only normal.

Meanwhile, after logging off the game, Yuan patiently waited for Yu Rou until she entered the room and began doing her daily routine.

"Yu Rou, I'm currently doing an important quest, and even though it might not happen until tomorrow morning, I'll be staying in the game for the night just in case," Yuan said to her.

"Oh? So you're finally playing the game seriously, Brother? Okay, I'll let you play. But you really shouldn't do this too often. I don't want your health to weaken because of it."

"Hahaha, you worry too much, Yu Rou. I have never felt better ever since I started playing the game, and there are even times when I feel as though my body is filled with energy. Of course, the only thing limiting me is my pathetic condition."

Sometime later, after being cleaned and fed by Yu Rou, Yuan returned to the game.

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Chapter 48 - In

A few minutes after Yuan returned to the game, Luo Li knocked on the door.

"Daoist Yuan, dinner is ready," she said to him.

"I'm coming!" Yuan said before coming out of the room with Xiao Hua.

Luo Li then led the two of them into a large room with a long table in the middle where the rest of her family was waiting.

"Thank you for accepting our invitation, Daoist Yuan." Lord Luo said to him after seeing him.

"No, I should be thanking you for inviting me."

"Please, have a seat." Lord Luo gestured to the two empty seats beside him and two servants pulled out the chair for them.

"Thank you..."

After taking a seat, Lord Luo clapped his hands. A few seconds later, the servants began carrying dishes after dishes into the room.

"I have heard about your impressive appetite to eat an entire menu and made sure to have enough food so that you don't have to worry about holding back." Lord Luo said to him with a bright smile as the table was being filled to the brim with food.

They began eating shortly afterward.

"..."

"..."

"..."

The Luo Family watched with wide eyes as Yuan consumed the food on the table as though he was a food monster.

Even Luo Li, who had seen him eat before, couldn't help but stare at Yuan with wide eyes.

'How can he still eat like that when he'd already consumed so much not too long ago? Where does the food go after entering his stomach? It's almost as though there is a black hole inside his stomach which could consume even the entire world!'

Meanwhile, Lord Luo was beginning to worry about what might happen to their family's finances if they had to feed Yuan like this every day.

A little over an hour later, after they finished eating and the servants carried away the empty dishes, Lord Luo looked at Yuan and said to him, "Daoist Yuan, now that dinner is finished, why don't we have a little conversation? My family would like to ask you some questions."

"Since you have satisfied my stomach, I don't mind answering a few questions. What would you like to know?" Yuan said.

"Do you have any hobbies?" Luo Li was the first to ask him.

"It may sound simple, but I enjoy doing anything that requires me to exert myself. Whether it be hunting monsters or simply walking around town, I enjoy it all."

"I think it's wonderful." Luo Li said with an alluring smile.

"I will ask the next question," said Luo Ming. "Since you mentioned hunting monsters, what's the strongest beast you've defeated so far?"

"The strongest beasts, huh? I defeated a Demonic Spider that was at the fourth level Spirit Warrior realm not long before arriving at this place."

Yuan said in a calm voice.

"A Demonic Spider?!" Luo Ming exclaimed in a shocked voice. "Y-You are stronger than I'd expected, Daoist Yuan. Even the Elders at my sect would have trouble fighting a Demonic Spider..."

"..."

The other people in the room had similar expressions as Luo Ming after learning that Yuan had defeated a Demonic Spider. If only they knew that he'd obliterated it with a single strike.

A few moments later, Luo Ling asked him, "You don't have to answer this if you don't want to, Daoist Yuan, but do you have a Dao Companion?"

"..."

The room instantly turned silent with everyone's gaze staring intensely at Yuan, especially Luo Li, whose heart was beating loudly.

"Dao...Companion...?" Yuan lifted his eyebrows at this unfamiliar term. "I'm sorry, but what is a Dao Companion?"

Albeit a little bit surprised by his question, Luo Ling responded with a smile on her face, "A Dao Companion is someone you walk the cultivation path with for the rest of your life— a spouse so to speak."

"Like a wife? Then no, I do not have someone like that. I am way too young to be thinking about something like that." Yuan shook his head.

"What are you talking about, Daoist Yuan? You are already eligible for marriage at the age of 16! Then what about a girlfriend? Surely, someone as talented and handsome as you should have one or two already, right?" Luo Ling continued to ask him with a brave expression on her face.

"No... I also don't have someone like that..." he said with a bitter smile on his face.

'I am in no position to have someone like that in my life as I do not want them to waste their time on someone in my condition, and I'm sure that nobody would be willing to accept me if they knew about my real identity...' Yuan sighed inwardly.

Even if someone in the real world would be willing to take care of him, Yuan wasn't sure that he'd be able to endure the guilt, as his heart is already filled to the brim with guilt for making Yu Rou take care of him.

"I see... I'm sorry if my questions made you feel awkward, Daoist Yuan." Luo Ling apologized to him afterward. She then turned to look at Luo Li and winked at her.

Seeing this, Luo Li blushed.

"Anyway..."

Just as Lord Luo opened his mouth to speak, the door slammed open before a guard came rushing into the room.

"Who dares?! Do you have no manners?!" Lord Luo shouted at the guard who came into the room.

However, the guard ignored his anger and quickly said, "Please excuse my sudden entrance, Lord Luo! This is an emergency! There are thousands of beasts from the Pang Mountain rushing here as we speak!"

"What?!" Lord Luo immediately stood up with a surprised face, "The Mountain Lord is already attacking us?! I was told they wouldn't attack until tomorrow morning! This is too sudden!"

"Whatever! I will deal with whoever gave us the intel after we settle this situation!"

Lord Luo then turned to look at Yuan and said, "I deeply apologize for this, especially when you just filled your stomach, but it appears the Mountain Lord has already begun its revenge."

Yuan shook his head and said, "This just means I have more energy to fight with."

"Gather all of the guards and prepare to defend the city!" Lord Luo then ordered the guard.

Once the guard disappeared, Lord Luo said to his children, "I want the three of you to follow Daoist Yuan and defend the city with him. I am going to deal with the Mountain Lord."

"Yes, father!" They nodded.

A few moments later, Lord Luo also rushed outside.

"Please take care of us, Daoist Yuan."

The Luo Family bowed to Yuan afterward.

Sometime later, a notification appeared above Pang City.

«Event 'Mountain Lord's Invasion' has begun!»

«Slay the monsters attacking Pang City to receive points!»

«The Player with the highest points at the end will receive a special reward!»

"An in-game event?" Yuan looked at the notification in the sky with his interest piqued.

Chapter 49 - Domineering Presence

After seeing the notification on the sky and not wanting to let the others get ahead of him in points, Yuan quickly said to the others, "Let's go!"

Yuan and the Luo Family proceeded to run outside the city gates, where hundreds of people were already gathered.

There were around one hundred people wearing similar-looking armors whilst the rest of the people there were wearing common and unmatching gear. It was obvious who the players were and who were the NPCs at a glance.

'There are so many Players here...' Yuan was slightly surprised, even feeling a little nervous, worried that he might reveal his identity once he starts fighting.

"Xiao Hua..." he suddenly called for her, and he asked her, "Do you have any equipment that covers the face? Something like a mask..."

Not even questioning why he needed it, Xiao Hua nodded before rummaging her storage pouch.

"Here you go, Brother Yuan." Xiao Hua handed him an elegant-looking black face mask that could cover his entire face.

"Thank you, Xiao Hua. I will return it to you later," he said as he accepted the mask.

«Black Jade Mask»

«Grade: Spirit»

«Quality: Peak»

«Mental Strength Required: 2,500»

«Description: A profound mask that increases your Mental Defense by 5,000»

"Just like the sword, Brother Yuan can keep it." Xiao Hua said to him afterward.

Yuan nodded, and immediately after wearing the mask, he could feel his mind easing and feeling more tranquil.

The Luo Family wondered why Yuan felt the need to hide his face, but they didn't have time to ask him as someone there suddenly shouted with excitement, "The monsters are here!"

Once the people there heard that, they all retrieved their weapons and prepared to fight.

Very soon, hundreds of monsters between the third level and seventh level Spirit Apprentice could be seen rushing towards the city walls.

"DEFEND THE CITY!"

The guards roared loudly, causing the atmosphere to instantly change, and the place there quickly became a battlefield with both the NPCs and the Players engaged in fights with the monsters.

Yuan and the Luo Family also began attacking the monsters.

«+2 Points»

«+3 Points»

«+1 Point»

After Yuan swiftly beheaded three monsters with only normal sword techniques, he rushed to the front lines where there were barely any people

but filled with monsters and began slaying even more monsters with ease, each with a single sword strike.

The monsters that were slain by Yuan did not even have a chance to scream before becoming a corpse, and when the Luo Family saw how effortlessly he was slaying these monsters, their eyes widened with admiration and awe.

Granted, Yuan was a Spirit Warrior fighting monsters way below his level, but the way he so effortlessly executed the monsters was nothing short of perfection, and it was almost like a walk in the park for him.

However, it was not just the Luo Family that were surprised by Yuan's prowess, as the other Players have also taken notice of his domineering presence on the battlefield.

"Who the hell is that single-man-army?! He's killing the monsters as though they are defenseless chickens!"

"He's probably some expert NPC assisting with the situation!"

"Forget about him! Look at the little girl next to him! She's killing the monsters with her bare hands! And she's even making it look so effortless!"

The people there watched as Xiao Hua slapped every monster that dared to attack her with a single slap to the face, shocking everybody there greatly.

«+1 Point»

«+2 Points»

«+2 Points»

«+1 Point»

«+3 Points»

Points continuously flowed for Yuan even when Xiao Hua killed the monsters, racking up over two hundred points within mere minutes.

Meanwhile, the other players were having trouble dealing with just a single monster, and most of them had less than 10 points even after many minutes.

'How many monsters are there?!' Yuan cried inwardly after slaying over 500 monsters but was still surrounded by them.

He also wanted to use Heaven Splitting Sword Strike to clear the mobs faster, but he did not want to destroy the place in the process, as the Pang City was right behind him, so he could only give up on such thoughts and defeat the monsters without any flashy attacks.

"Daoist Yuan, the beasts coming here are growing stronger! The Mountain Lord should be near!" Luo Ling suddenly said to him.

"The Mountain Lord? If we kill it, won't its subordinates stop attacking the city?"

"Yes, and our father should be fighting the Mountain Lord right now!"

Yuan nodded, "Then let's continue defending the city until he defeats the Mountain Lord!"

"Bloody Sword Strike!"

The sword in Yuan's hand flickered, and three more monsters were slain in a single strike.

«Your comprehension with Bloody Sword Strike has reached a new level»

«Bloody Sword Strike Mastery Level (2) → (3)»

«Bloody Sword Strike»

«Rank: Earth»

«Mastery Level: 3»

«Description: Consumes 900,000 Qi. Must wield a sword to activate. A technique from the Blood Sect.»

"Ha!"

After killing a few more hundred monsters with the sword, Yuan's comprehension improved again.

«Your mastery with the sword has improved significantly»

«You have learned 'Novice Sword Mastery'»

«Novice Sword Mastery»

«Description: Slightly improves your control with the sword by 15% and increases all damage dealt with swords by 10%. Your enemies will feel more pain from your sword attacks as your damage increases. Requires no activation.»

Many minutes of fighting later, as both Players and NPCs were beginning to run out of energy, someone wearing Pang City's armor approached the Luo Family and shouted at them in a panicked voice, "Young Ladies! Young Master! It's about your father, Lord Luo! He's currently in a critical condition after fighting with the Mountain Lord!"

"What?! What happened to our father?! And what about the Mountain Lord?!" Luo Ming quickly shouted back.

After taking a deep breath, the guard continued, "Lord Luo, he... he lost the fight against the Mountain Lord! However, he barely managed to escape with his life and is currently being treated by the doctors! And while his life is not in danger, he cannot continue fighting!"

"How could this be...?" Luo Li covered her mouth in shock, feeling lightheaded after hearing such news.

"Does this mean the Mountain Lord is still going on a rampage? If we don't defeat it soon, the monsters will eventually overwhelm the people here and destroy the city!" Luo Ming said with a frown.

"We will have to worry about our father later. Right now, we must defeat the Mountain Lord!" Luo Ling then turned to look at Yuan, who was still

slaying monsters not far away from them.

She then ran to him and said, "Daoist Yuan! We've just received news that our father lost to the Mountain Lord!"

"What?! Is your father okay?" Yuan said in a surprised tone.

She nodded and said, "His life is not in danger, but he won't be able to fight the Mountain Lord anymore, and you are the only one here that's strong enough to fight it. Please, help us defeat the Mountain Lord! I will do anything to repay you afterward!"

Yuan did not even need to think before nodding his head, "Okay, I will fight the Mountain Lord."

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Chapter 50 - Heavenly Domain

"Lead us to the Mountain Lord!" Luo Ling said to the guard.

However, before they leave, Yuan said to Xiao Hua, "I alone should be enough to handle the Mountain Lord. Can you stay behind to make sure the people here aren't overwhelmed by the monsters? You can come to me afterward."

The people there were already looking exhausted and he cannot imagine what might happen to the defense here if he were to leave so abruptly.

Xiao Hua nodded and said, "Xiao Hua will take care of the beasts here."

"Thank you, Xiao Hua."

"The two of you also stay here and help her," Luo Ling said to her siblings.

Yuan then followed Luo Ling and the guard to the Mountain Lord whilst Luo Li and Luo Ming stayed behind with Xiao Hua to assist the people.

Once Yuan was gone, Luo Li bowed to Xiao Hua, "Senior Xiao, please take care of us."

Xiao Hua nodded, and she turned to look at the hundreds of monsters on the battlefield.

'It's going to take forever if I kill them one at a time...' she thought to herself.

'Brother Yuan said that I can use my powers as long as I am conscious of the surroundings and I don't destroy any nature...'

"Tell the guards the retreat." Xiao Hua suddenly said to Luo Li.

"R-Right away!" Luo Li nodded, not daring to doubt her words after seeing the serious expression on her face.

"Retreat! Guards! Retreat back to the gates!" Luo Li suddenly shouted loudly.

The guards quickly rushed back to the gates after hearing her words, even feeling relieved that they don't have to fight any longer.

However, the other players were left dumbfounded by this unexpected turn of events.

"What the heck?! What about the monsters?!"

"Are you trying to make us do all of the fighting, you damn NPC?!"

"Whatever! That just means more points for me!"

Despite the Players' anger, Luo Li ignored them and said to Xiao Hua, "Senior Xiao, the guards have retreated to the gates! Is this good enough for you?"

Xiao Hua nodded and took a deep breath before closing her eyes.

"..."

"..."

A few moments of silence later, she slowly opened her eyes, and her gaze flickered with a golden light that seemed to carry the Will of Heaven within.

She calmly raised her right arm into the air before pressing her palms down in a profound manner.

"Heavenly Domain..." Xiao Hua mumbled in a low voice.

BOOM!

Xiao Hua's Spirit King cultivation base suddenly exploded, causing the dark sky to brighten, and the entire place became filled with a golden light, almost as though they were bathed in sunlight.

"W-What is this golden light?! What is going on?!"

Both the players and the guards were baffled by this phenomenon.

In the midst of the players' confusion, the monsters suddenly began screaming in pain, sounding as though they were being slaughtered before...

Splat!

The monsters within the golden light— within Xiao Hua's Heavenly Domain were crushed into meat paste, almost as though an invisible boulder had suddenly fallen on them, squashing them flat.

And within mere seconds, only flattened beast corpses remained within the Heavenly Domain.

"..."

The place turned dead silent after the people there witnessed this shocking scene and Xiao Hua's terrifying prowess.

Meanwhile, on the other side of the city, Yuan was shocked when he suddenly gained thousands of points at once.

«+1,169 Points»

«+1,014 Points»

«+2,841 Points»

'What the heck? Where did all of these points come from? I hope Xiao Hua didn't go overboard again...' Yuan cried inwardly.

"There's the Mountain Lord!" The guard suddenly said.

"That's the Mountain Lord...?" Yuan was speechless when he saw a group of guards trying to fight a massive 7-meter tall black bear in the distance.

Luo Ling nodded with a serious expression on her face, "Indeed, that's the Mountain Lord—the Black Beast, and it seems to have advanced to the sixth level Spirit Warrior realm since the last time we saw it. No wonder why my father lost to it..."

"Do you think you can defeat it?" Luo Ling turned to look at him with a worried expression, as she was worried that she was asking too much from him.

"I will try my best," Yuan responded a moment later.

"Don't push yourself too hard, Daoist Yuan. If you cannot defeat it, just run away."

"How can I possibly do such a thing knowing that the city might fall if I don't defeat it here?" Yuan quickly shook his head.

"Daoist Yuan..." Luo Ling looked at him with a passionate gaze, looking like a child before her hero or a teenager before her idol.

A few moments later, once they were close enough, Luo Ling shouted at the guards that were already at their limit, "Get back! Reinforcement is here!"

"Young Lady!" A blissful expression appeared on the guards' faces when they saw Luo Ling's face and the masked expert beside her who was emitting a profound aura.

"I will assist you to the best of my ability, Daoist Yuan," she said to him after they arrived before the Mountain Lord.

Yuan nodded and stared at the Mountain Lord with a serious gaze through the holes in his mask.

'What a terrifying gaze and a bloodthirsty aura. This Mountain Lord is, without doubt, stronger than the Demonic Spider...'

Despite facing such a threatening opponent, Yuan was feeling calmer than when he fought the Demonic Spider. Perhaps it was due to the Black Jade Mask's effect, or maybe he was simply getting used to these situations, but his mind was completely tranquil at this moment.

"..."

When the Mountain Lord saw Yuan's confident aura, it narrowed its gaze and silently stared at him.

A few seconds later, it spoke in a grim voice, "No matter how many experts you humans bring, I will tear down this city and avenge my son!"

ROAAAR

The Mountain Lord released a deafening roar before it rushed at Yuan and Luo Ling with red eyes filled with killing intent, even causing the ground to tremble with each step it took.

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Chapter 51 - Achieving First Place

"Here it comes, Daoist Yuan!" Luo Ling quickly said to him.

Yuan nodded and raised his sword as the Mountain Lord lifted its massive claws and swung at them.

Boom!

Yuan felt as though a large boulder was trying to crush him when he blocked the Mountain Lord's strike.

"I will back you up!" Luo Ling used this chance to thrust her sword at the Mountain Lord's face, but alas, with a single roar from the Mountain Lord, Luo Ling was sent flying away from the tremendous air pressure.

"Luo Ling! Are you okay?!" Yuan asked her whilst he pushed the Mountain Lord's claw to the side.

"I-I am not hurt..." she quickly responded.

"Get lost, you human ant! You don't have the qualifications to meddle in our battle!" The Mountain Lord roared at her.

"I understand that you are angry because of what happened to your child, but do you really have to kill so many innocent people and destroy an entire city for revenge?!" Yuan suddenly said.

"Don't try to persuade me, brat! I will kill everyone in this city even if it's the last thing I do and there's nothing you can do to stop it!"

The Mountain Lord roared again, and its aura began growing more powerful and tyrannical.

"If that's the case, then watch me stop you!" Yuan's eyes flickered with a bright light and his sword began trembling, almost as though it was filled with excitement.

"Bloody Sword Strike!"

A red light flashed before the Mountain Lord's eyes and before it could even react, Yuan's sword was already directly in front of its eyes.

"?!"

The Mountain Lord quickly closed its eyelids to protect its eyes with its steel-like skin, but alas, Yuan's sword was much sharper than it'd anticipated and pierced right through its tough skin.

"Aaaaaaagh!!!"

The Mountain Lord screamed in pain as blood squirted from its eyes.

"Che! I couldn't reach the brain and kill it in one shot." Yuan sucked his teeth after pulling his sword out of the Mountain Lord's face with effort.

"I will kill you! I will fucking kill you!"

The Mountain Lord roared before rushing at Yuan with its claws swinging recklessly.

Seeing this, Yuan immediately focused on dodging its strikes, feeling the tremendous pressure from each strike as it brushed by his face. If the Mountain Lord successfully hit him even once, he will most likely turn into meat paste and die.

After dodging a dozen strikes, Yuan finally saw an opportunity to strike back and quickly stabbed his sword at the Mountain Lord's uninjured eye.

"AAAAAAGH! HOW DARE YOU?!"

Without its sights, the Mountain Lord was severely crippled in its movements and ability to defend itself from Yuan's incoming attacks.

"It sucks without the ability to see, right? I know that feeling very well! And I am giving you one last chance to leave before I really kill you!" Yuan said, feeling that it was only right to show mercy to the Mountain Lord who had lost its child to a human even though it was a monster, not to mention that it was once peaceful with humans.

"Even if I leave today, my hatred for humans and for this place will never subdue! Unless you kill me today, I will definitely return for revenge!"

"Then you leave me with no other choice!" Yuan narrowed his eyes with a resolute feeling, and he tightened his grasp on the sword.

"Bloody Sword Strike!"

Yuan rushed at the Mountain Lord before thrusting his sword forward, and because the Mountain Lord could not see, it was unable to react, allowing Yuan to pierce its neck with ease.

«Congratulations! Player Yuan has become the first Player to kill the Elite Boss: Black Beast!»

«You have subdued the Lord of Pang Mountain!»

«+10 Fame»

«+5,000 Points»

«You have successfully defended Pang City from the Mountain Lord's Invasion!»

An announcement announcing the end of the event suddenly appeared above Pang City for all players to see after Mountain Lord was slain by Yuan, followed by another announcement a few moments later.

«Player Yuan has amassed a grand total of 11,690 points during this event, obtaining the most points out of all participants and will receive a special reward for such an achievement!»

When the other players saw the familiar name 'Player Yuan', they immediately began shouting in excitement.

"It's Player Yuan! He's actually in this place right now!"

"Where is he?! Who is Player Yuan?!"

"Holy shit! 11 thousand points?! I only have 300 points after killing over a hundred monsters! Just how on earth did he obtain so many points in such a short time?!"

It was at that moment the players there realized something.

"W-Wait a second... There's only one person who can possibly have so many points! That little girl who used some overpowered technique to kill most of the monsters here!"

"Now that you mentioned it, where is that little girl?!"

"Impossible! Player Yuan is actually a little girl?!"

"It all makes sense now! That golden light must have been a Divine-grade technique! No wonder why it was so powerful, even overpowered!"

"This new information is definitely going to shock the world!"

"Quick! Someone hurry and post it online! The world must know about this as soon as possible!"

"Hahaha! To think that we've been wasting our time looking for a male player when we should've been looking for a little girl this entire time! This is hilarious!"

The people there began logging off to spread the news on the internet, completely unaware of the chaos this misunderstanding will cause in the future.

Meanwhile, the real Player Yuan was silently staring at the Mountain Lord's corpse, feeling slightly guilty for killing it, as any normal human would go

crazy from sorrow if their children were killed.

"I cannot thank you enough for protecting the Pang City and the innocent citizens that live here, Daoist Yuan." Luo Ling had unknowingly appeared behind him and said to him with her head lowered.

"Thank you for defeating the Mountain Lord, Senior Yuan!" The guards also bowed to him at a 90-degree angle.

"There's no need to thank me. Although it had a valid reason for wanting revenge, I could not allow an entire city to fall and thousands of innocent people to die because of it." Yuan said to them.

A few moments later, Xiao Hua returned to his side and said, "Well done, Brother Yuan."

"You too, Xiao Hua."

"Daoist Yuan, the guards will handle everything from here. Let's return to my father's side for now. He needs to know that the city is no longer in danger." Luo Ling said to him sometime later.

While Luo Ling led Yuan back to the Lord's Manor, the real world was in utter chaos from the new information regarding Player Yuan that had just appeared on the internet.

[Shocking News! Player Yuan is actually female—and a little girl at that!]

[New information regarding Player Yuan has surfaced!]

[Player Yuan is currently at Pang City!]

The new information on Player Yuan shocked the whole world collectively. However, not everyone was willing to believe this new information despite the convincing evidence from the Players that had participated in defending Pang City, as it was simply too unbelievable that some little girl without any background could possibly be the number one player in the world.

There were even some people who wanted to see for themselves whether this information was true, so they began making their way towards Pang City regardless of how far away they were from the place at the moment.

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Chapter 52 - Pang City's Hero

Chapter 52 - Pang City's Hero

"Father! Are you okay?!" Luo Ling went straight to her father's room where he was being treated after returning home.

"Ling'er... why are you here...? What happened to defending the city? What about the Mountain Lord...?" Lord Luo asked them with an anxious face while laying on the bed with bloodied bandages all over his body.

"Please calm down and listen to me, father! Everything has been resolved by Daoist Yuan! He not only defended the city gates from the invasion but even defeated the Mountain Lord by himself! The city is safe!" Luo Ling explained the situation to him with a bright face.

"W-What?! Is that true? Our Pang City is no longer in danger?!" Lord Luo's eyes flickered with emotions after hearing the news.

"Yes, father. It's all true, so you can rest and focus on healing your injuries." Luo Ling said to him.

"I-I don't know what to say, Daoist Yuan... I really don't know how to thank you for your contribution... If not for my condition, I would even kowtow to you right now..." Lord Luo said to him with a grateful expression.

"Your feelings are more than enough," Yuan said with a smile.

"No, that cannot do! I must thank you properly!"

An idea suddenly flashed inside his head, and he quickly said, "I know! You can have my daughter! And if Luo Li alone is not good enough for you, I can also give you Luo Ling here! And if you don't want to make them your wife, they can be your concubines!"

"Uh..."

Yuan looked at Lord Luo with a baffled expression, but before he could even respond, Lord Luo looked at Luo Ling and asked her, "What do you think, Ling'er? Are you willing to serve Daoist Yuan even as a concubine? You probably won't find someone like him again."

"Wait a..."

And as Yuan opened his mouth, Luo Ling bashfully nodded her head with a rosy face.

"I am willing," she mumbled in a low but clear voice.

The door opened a second later and the rest of the Luo Family entered the room.

"Father! How are your injuries?!" Luo Ming asked him without having a single clue as to what kind of situation he'd just walked into.

"Father!" Luo Li also approached the bed with a worried expression on her face.

However, instead of telling them that he was okay to calm them down, Lord Luo instead looked at Luo Li and said to her, "Li'er! I have already heard about the situation from Ling'er, and I am thinking about giving your hand and Ling'er's to Daoist Yuan for saving our city, and your elder sister has already agreed to become his concubine."

"Eh?! What?!" Luo Li immediately looked at Luo Ling with a shocked face.

"I'm sorry, little sister. I know that you already have feelings for Daoist Yuan, but I have also fallen for him..."

"Elder sister..." Luo Li looked at her with a perplexed feeling in her heart.

However, in the midst of their conversation, Yuan loudly cleared his throat and said, "Excuse me. I am flattered by your feelings, but I have already said that I am too young to marry, much less two of you."

"That's fine, Daoist Yuan! If you want to marry them in a few years, they can wait for you! I can also assure you that they have never been in a relationship before, so they are still maidens!" Lord Luo quickly said, clearly adamant about giving his daughters to him as a reward for saving the city.

"T-That's not what I am trying to say—"

"Are we not good enough for you, Daoist Yuan...?" Luo Ling suddenly asked him with a disheartened expression.

"Eh? I never said that..." Yuan quickly shook his head, feeling slightly overwhelmed by the situation as he has never been in this kind of situation before.

"If Daoist Yuan does not feel comfortable with us now, we are willing to wait until you are ready to accept us however long that might take... even if it's only as your concubines." Luo Li said to him a moment later.

Yuan was speechless. Why do they want to be with him so much? Or are they programmed to like whoever saves the city?

'What the heck even is a concubine?!' Yuan cried inwardly.

While Yuan was pondering in silence, Xiao Hua spoke in a calm voice, "Brother Yuan is destined to become a great figure who will rule the cultivation world in future, and there will be no lack of women who will want to be with him. Xiao Hua won't speak of your qualifications, but it won't be long before Brother Yuan challenges the Stairway to Heaven, and once that happens, who knows if you'll still be alive by the time he returns here."

"What?! Daoist Yuan is going to challenge the Stairway to Heaven?!"

Everyone in the room was shocked to hear Xiao Hua's words, but Yuan couldn't understand why. What even is this Stairway to Heaven?

"So we are underestimating Daoist Yuan even now... To think he'd be brave enough to participate in the Stairway to Heaven..." Luo Ming said with an awkward smile.

"If Daoist Yuan really plans on climbing the Stairway to Heaven, we will only become a burden for you. I'm sorry, Daoist Yuan, but you can forget about our conversation just now." Luo Ling released a deep sigh.

However, Luo Li's gaze remained resolved, and she said, "Daoist Yuan... If you still remember me by the time your adventure ends, please do visit this place again. I will wait for you until my last breath."

"..."

Seeing the sincere emotions in her gaze, Yuan couldn't help but nod his head.

"Although I don't know what will happen in the future, I definitely won't forget about you or my experience in this place," Yuan said with an innocent smile. "The next time we meet, let's eat together again, okay?"

"Un! It's a promise, Daoist... No, Brother Yuan!" Luo Li nodded with slightly teary eyes.

"Don't forget about me neither, okay?" Luo Ling also said to him.

"I won't," he nodded still with a smile on his face.

«Congratulations! Because of your massive contributions during 'Mountain Lord's Invasion', you have been awarded the unique title 'Pang City's Hero'!»

«Pang City's Hero»

«Description: Bearing the title of Hero, your reputation within Pang City will always be at the maximum, and your overall cultivation speed will increase by 10%»

«'Luo Li' has been added to your Bond!»

«Luo Li's Bond level has increased to Acquaintance!»

«Luo Li's Bond level has increased to Friend!»

«Luo Li's Bond level has increased to Intimate!»

«Congratulations! Your Bond level with Luo Li has reached Intimate!»

«You have gained the following effect from Luo Li's Bond level: 'Luo Li's Adoration'»

«Luo Li's Adoration: Increases your Charm by 10 and Overall Damage by 15%.»

«Charm: Increases your overall attractiveness»

«Overall Damage: All of the damage you inflict to others will feel more painful»

«'Luo Ling' has been added to your Bond!»

«Luo Ling's Bond level has increased to Acquaintance!»

«Luo Ling's Bond level has increased to Friend!»

«Luo Ling's Bond level has increased to Intimate!»

«You have gained the following effect from Luo Ling's Bond level: 'Luo Ling's Adoration'»

«Luo Ling's Adoration: Increases your Charm by 20 and Luck by 10.»

«Luck: Increases the chances of monsters dropping their monster cores»

«'Pang City' has been added to your Associations!»

«Because of your heroic actions that saved the city, your relationship with 'Pang City' has increased significantly!»

«Because of your bond level with 'Luo Li', daughter of 'Luo Family', your relationship with Pang City has increased significantly!»

«Because of your bond level with 'Luo Ling', daughter of 'Luo Family', your relationship with Pang City has increased significantly!»

«Due to your actions at 'Pang City', your Fame has increased by 50!»

«Your relationship with Pang City has reached the maximum level!»

«Due to your relationship with Pang City, all monsters within a 1,000-mile radius from Pang City will drop their monster cores twice as often!»

Once the barrage of notifications had stopped for Yuan, he said to the Luo Family, "I will stay in this city for one more day just in case the monsters return."

"Please! You can stay here as long as you want! I wouldn't even mind if you lived here forever!" Lord Luo laughed loudly despite the pain in his body.

"By the way, I will properly award you for helping us once the preparations are complete." Lord Luo then said to him.

"You really don't have to..."

"There's no need to be humble. You are already like family to us, anyway! And you can just think of it as an early wedding gift or something like that! Hahaha!" Lord Luo laughed again.

Cough

"Fuck! That hurts!" Lord Luo cursed in a painful voice after laughing too hard.

"Get some rest already, father. We will take care of everything for you." Luo Ling said to him.

"Thank you..." he mumbled before falling asleep a few moments later.

"You can rest in your room, Brother Yuan. If you need anything, just let me know and I will do my best to assist you." Luo Li said to him with rosy cheeks before she quickly walked towards the door.

"See ya later, Brother Yuan!" Luo Ming casually waved at him.

Once Luo Li and Luo Ming left the room, Luo Ling approached his ears and whispered to him, "If my sister is not enough for you, you can call for me afterward."

She winked at him in a seductive manner before leaving the room, completely unaware that Yuan was too innocent to understand the meaning behind her words.

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Chapter 53 - Starry Abyss

"Did you hear? Player Yuan is currently at Pang City!"

"Where is that?"

"It's only 30 miles away from here. Want to go over there and take a look? There will be many other people who'll be going there to see for themselves whether Player Yuan is really a little girl or not."

"Let's go!"

After news of Player Yuan spread throughout the internet, thousands of Players began making their way towards Pang City in hopes of seeing Player Yuan, who was rumored to be a cute little girl.

Of course, Yuan himself was completely unaware of the misunderstanding about him that had spread throughout the internet, and he was silently cultivating in the Lord's Manor.

A few hours have passed since the Mountain Lord's invasion, and Luo Li took a deep breath before knocking on the door to Yuan's room.

Knock *Knock*

"Brother Yuan, it's Luo Li," she said to him from outside.

"You can come inside," Yuan responded a moment later.

"Were you cultivating? I hope I didn't interrupt your cultivation..." Luo Li said after seeing the spiritual energy that was gathered around him.

"It's okay. I was about to take a break anyway." Yuan said as he got off the bed, feeling a little bit stiff from sitting in the same position for many hours.

"Do you need something from me?" he asked her a moment later.

"Quite the opposite, actually. We have finished preparing the reward for your contribution during the Mountain Lord's invasion, and we would like you to receive it now,' she said.

"Okay." Yuan nodded before following her outside with Xiao Hua by his side.

A few minutes later, they entered this massive long room with Lord Luo sitting on a large chair at the end of the room, and he was still wrapped in bandages.

Luo Ming and Luo Ling were also in the same room, as were all of the servants in the building and a few guards.

Once Luo Li brought Yuan to the front, Lord Luo spoke in a clear voice, "Daoist Yuan, I have said this before, but I will say it again. Neither I— nor this city can thank you enough for what you have done for this place, and one can even say that you are the sole reason why this city and the thousands of citizens that live here are still alive right now."

"Although this reward isn't much, it's the most precious item our Pang City can afford."

Lord Luo suddenly clapped his hands, and two servants approached Yuan with two boxes in their grasp.

Once they opened the boxes, Lord Luo continued to speak, "For your contributions, from defending the Pang City from thousands of beasts to defeating the Mountain Lord, my Luo Family shall award you with 1,000,000 gold coins and our Luo Family's heirloom, the Starry Abyss."

Inside one of the boxes was a small storage pouch that contained 1,000,000 gold coins, whilst the other bigger box contained a beautiful dagger with a

golden handle and a pitch-black blade that seemed to be made from some kind of jade.

"The Starry Abyss has been passed down in my family for over ten generations, but nobody in the family has ever been able to wield it, almost as though it has its own consciousness. Perhaps you, Daoist Yuan, who will be climbing the Stairway to Heaven one day, might be able to wield it."

'A dagger...? But I have only ever practiced with a sword...' Yuan looked at the flickering black dagger that appeared to contain an entire universe within with a dazed expression, feeling some kind of connection to it.

"Brother Yuan, that's a Soul Weapon..." Xiao Hua suddenly said to him in a low voice, and when Yuan turned to look at her, he could only see a shocked expression on her face.

However, since this wasn't the time or situation to ask her for an explanation, Yuan could only wait until later to ask her.

"Thank you very much for your gift. I swear that I will keep it safe no matter what." Yuan humbly bowed to them before he accepted the gift, as he learned that bowing in this world meant a display of respect after seeing it so many times.

«Congratulations! You have obtained a Soul Weapon!»

Once Yuan accepted the gifts, an announcement appeared in the sky for everyone but Yuan to see.

«Congratulations! Player Yuan has become the first Player to obtain a Soul Weapon!»

However, the players were puzzled by the announcement, as this is their first time hearing about Soul Weapons. What even is a Soul Weapon, and how does it differ from regular weapons?

Once the rewards have been distributed, Lord Luo then said to Yuan, "By the way, we have collected all of the monster cores from Mountain Lord's

invasion. We were able to collect 241 monster cores at the Spirit Apprentice level and the Mountain Lord's Spirit Warrior realm monster core, and I'd also like to give them all to you, as you were the one who killed most of them, anyway."

However, Yuan said, "You can have the Spirit Apprentice level monster cores, I only need the Spirit Warrior monster core."

"Are you sure, Daoist Yuan? If you sold them, you could earn some more gold."

He nodded and said, "1,000,000 gold coins is more than enough for me right now. If anything, I'd like to donate those monster cores to the guards who also risked their lives defending the city yesterday."

When the guards in the room heard Yuan's words, their faces immediately brightened, and they silently thanked Yuan in their hearts.

"I understand. If that's your request, I will leave the Mountain Lord's monster core with you and share the rest with the guards." Lord Luo nodded with an approving smile on his face. Good-natured Cultivators like Yuan are hard to come by nowadays, and he cannot be any happier to know that his daughters might be taken care of by someone like him in the future.

Sometime later, Lord Luo said to him, "Breakfast is almost done, Daoist Yuan. Are you interested?"

"Of course!" He nodded without hesitation.

Chapter 54 - Soul Weapons

Once breakfast finished and Yuan returned to his room, he asked Xiao Hua, "What's a Soul Weapon?"

"Soul Weapons are as its name suggests— weapons that contain a soul, allowing it to have its own consciousness. They are exceedingly rare treasures even in the higher realms with nearly unlimited potential. And due to their uniqueness, they do not have specific Grades like ordinary weapons do. It's really shocking that the Luo Family would have something like this." Xiao Hua explained to him.

"A weapon with a soul... so there's somebody inside the weapon? How does that even happen?" Yuan asked, still confused about the concept.

"That's not quite right, Brother Yuan. There's nobody in the weapon. The term 'soul' does not actually mean there's someone in the weapon. It's just a weapon with just enough consciousness to pick their Masters."

"Oh... So I cannot talk with it?" Yuan said with a slightly disappointed expression.

"That might not be the case either, Brother Yuan. Because Soul Weapons are essentially living weapons that grow stronger with their Master, there's a chance its 'soul' can evolve in the future, allowing it to speak."

"Soul Weapons can grow stronger? No wonder why you say it has unlimited potential."

Xiao Hua nodded and said, "However, in order for it to grow, Brother Yuan must be able to wield it first, and Soul Weapons are not easy to control. Because regardless of your cultivation base, if the Soul Weapon does not

recognize you as its Master, it will be no different from an ordinary weapon, perhaps even worse."

Yuan nodded.

He then retrieved the beautiful black dagger and stared at it with a mesmerizing face.

«Starry Abyss»

«Level: 0»

«Rank: Soul Weapon»

«Growth Rate: Very Slow»

«Requirement: ???»

«Description: A beautiful dagger with an unknown origin. Appears to contain its own universe within the blade»

"How do I get it to recognize me?" Yuan asked her a moment later.

"Brother Yuan can try feeding it some of your blood to see whether it will recognize you or not." Xiao Hua suggested.

"Feed it my blood? How much blood?"

"A few drops should be enough," she said.

Yuan nodded and took a deep breath before pricking his finger with the tip of the Starry Abyss, feeding it a few drops of his own blood.

The moment Yuan's blood touched the dagger, his blood sunk into the dagger's blade, and Yuan could see his blood being absorbed by the flickering stars inside the blade.

A few seconds later, the dagger began trembling.

"W-What is going on, Xiao Hua?" Yuan asked her with a nervous expression.

"It's reacting to your blood, Brother Yuan! There's a good chance it will recognize you! Quickly, feed it more of your blood!" She urged him with excitement on her face.

Yuan nodded and squeezed a few more drops of blood onto the shaking dagger.

As the dagger absorbed more of Yuan's blood, the trembling grew stronger, and the dagger itself even started heating up.

"It's burning me!" Yuan dropped the dagger when it became unbearably hot to hold.

However, as though gravity stopped working, the Starry Abyss did not fall to the floor and remained levitating before Yuan.

After spending a few moments suspended in midair, the Starry Abyss finally stopped trembling.

"Try touching it, Brother Yuan." Xiao Hua suddenly said to him.

Yuan nodded and reached for the dagger.

After poking it a few times to make sure it wasn't hot, Yuan grabbed the dagger.

«Congratulations! You have been recognized by the Starry Abyss as its new Master!»

«You have obtained the title 'Soul Weapon Master'»

"I did it, Xiao Hua! It recognized me as its new Master!" Feeling some sort of connection with the dagger, Yuan said to her in excitement afterward.

Xiao Hua nodded with a smile, "The Soul Weapon definitely recognizes Brother Yuan's unlimited potential."

"How do I make it grow stronger?" he asked her.

"Soul Weapons will naturally grow strong with the Master, so as long as Brother Yuan continues growing stronger so will the Soul Weapon. Though, if you wish to make it grow faster, you can hunt monsters with the Soul Weapon so it can absorb their blood and grow stronger that way."

"But I don't know any dagger techniques besides the Thousand Knife Technique, and that's for cooking," he said.

"Even seemingly innocent and useless techniques like cooking techniques can become deadly in combat if used properly, Brother Yuan."

Yuan nodded and said, "I guess I can try using the Thousand Knife Technique with this dagger on weaker monsters when I have the time."

Meanwhile, in Lord Luo's room, a guard said to him, "Lord Luo, there has been an influx of visitors at our city ever since the Mountain Lord's invasion, and they're all Cultivators."

"What? Do you know why?" Lord Luo asked.

"We asked them for their reason for coming to our city, and a few of them said that they were here for 'Player Yuan'."

"Do they mean Daoist Yuan? But why would so many people come here just to see him?" Lord Luo pondered out loud.

"We have also asked them that question, but they did not provide us with any good reasons, saying things like they simply wanted to meet him."

Lord Luo nodded his head and said to the guard a few moments later, "Notify Daoist Yuan of the situation. Since these people came here for him, it'd be for the best to let him decide what we should do in this situation."

Sometime later, the guard explained the situation to Yuan, who was sweating by the end.

"Don't let them know that I am here! In fact, tell them that I have long left the city!" Yuan quickly said to the guard, who was slightly dumbfounded by his reaction, looking like he was on the run or something.

'It looks like Senior Yuan is more popular than we'd anticipated.' The guard thought to himself.

"Understood. We won't let them bother Senior Yuan no matter what." The guard said to him before leaving the room.

'Damn! This must be due to the announcement! Now every player in the world knows that I am in this city! I must leave this place as soon as possible!' Yuan sighed inwardly.

'However, it's too dangerous to leave now when there are so many people looking for me outside. I will leave once there are fewer people tomorrow.'

With that decided, Yuan returned to cultivating in silence to calm his mind.

Chapter 55 - Yu Rou's Evaluation

Chapter 55 - Yu Rou's Evaluation

Once Yuan realized that there were many people visiting Pang City to see him, he remained inside the Lord's Manor until it was dark outside, and after eating dinner with the Luo Family, he logged out and waited for Yu Rou to feed him once again.

"Brother, how is your progress in the game?" Yu Rou asked him as she wiped his body with a wet towel.

"Fairly good. I have made some new friends and got to eat some amazing food," he responded with a smile.

"Oh? Tell me about these new friends," she quickly asked him.

"Well, they are only NPCs, but they feel as real as Players with almost no distinctions between them."

"I have heard about that, too. Despite being NPCs, you will not be able to tell the difference between a Player and an NPC unless they start talking about our world."

"Yes, it's really shocking how realistic the world is."

Sometime later, once Yu Rou finished feeding and cleaning Yuan, she said to him, "Brother, I will be able to play with you after tomorrow. Where are you currently in the game? I will be entering the game after this and see where I start so that we can arrange a meeting once I begin playing."

"Me? I am in a place called Pang City," he responded without thinking.

"Hm? Pang City? Isn't that where the famous Player Yuan was last seen? Did you by any chance see this person?" Yu Rou asked him.

"P-Player Yuan? I have no idea..." Yuan quickly said.

"What a pity. I wanted to confirm whether the rumors are true or not," she sighed after hearing his words.

"Rumors? What kind of rumors?" Yuan asked her with his interest intrigued.

"Well, there were some players that had participated in the event at Pang City who claimed that they have seen Player Yuan with their own eyes and that 'he' is actually a 'she'." Yu Rou explained to him what she read on the internet.

"What the heck?!" Yuan cried out loud in a shocked voice. Why would anyone call him a female?

"I was shocked too when I first saw this information online. Apparently, she's a little girl who can use a very powerful technique that wiped out hundreds of monsters in the blink of an eye."

"A little girl...?"

If Yuan could feel his body right now, he would definitely be feeling the cold sweat soaking his back right now.

'How on earth did they mistake Xiao Hua as me?' he cried inwardly.

"I...I have a feeling that this information might be wrong..." Yuan suddenly said to her.

"Eh? What makes you say that?" Yu Rou asked him.

"I don't know. It's just a feeling I am getting," he responded.

"What a coincidence, Brother, as I am also getting a similar feeling." Yu Rou said.

"You seem very interested in this Player Yuan, why is that?" Yuan asked her a moment later.

"Even if you weren't interested in something at first, you will eventually become intrigued by it if you keep seeing it online constantly. Though, I am more interested in this Player's Servant more than anything."

"Servant?"

"Un." Yu Rou nodded, and she continued, "Because I personally don't like violence or fighting, I want to become a Cultivator who has servants that will fight for me, and I cannot help but wonder what a Divine-grade servant might look like. Any monster with such a high grade must be extremely powerful, right? Like a Phoenix or a Dragon."

'Actually, she's human... and a little girl at that...' Yuan responded to Yu Rou in his head.

After talking for a few minutes, mostly about what kind of servants she wants once she starts playing the game, Yu Rou said to him, "It's getting late, Brother. I am going to create my character tonight, and I will tell you where I am tomorrow morning."

"Okay. Good night, Yu Rou."

"Good night, Brother."

Yu Rou closed the lights before leaving the room.

'Since Yu Rou wants to have servants, I should ask Xiao Hua tomorrow if there are any methods to tame monsters...' Yuan thought to himself before falling asleep.

Meanwhile, inside her room, Yu Rou laid on the bed with the helmet used to play Cultivation Online on her head.

A brief moment after pressing the power button, Yu Rou could feel her consciousness slowly being transported to another place by a mysterious force.

Sometime later, when she opened her eyes, an old man with a profound gaze was already staring at her a few meters away, and they appeared to be

inside this white room.

"Hello..." Yu Rou took the initiation to speak to him.

"What is your name?" he asked her in a deep but clear voice.

"Yu Rou."

"Place your hand on this." The old man pushed a crystal ball towards her.

Yu Rou nodded and placed her hand on the crystal ball.

A few moments later, her status appeared.

Name: Yu Rou

Cultivation: None

Legacy: None

Bloodline: None

Physique: Pure Yin Physique

Physical Strength: 62

Mental Strength: 80

Soul Strength: 54

Physical Defense: 40

Mental Defense: 90

A disappointed light flickered within the old man's eyes after he saw Yu Rou's status, and he sighed inwardly, 'Another one with just above average talent, huh? Why am I so unlucky compared to that cold woman who encountered someone with the legendary Heaven Refining Physique? I am now certain that Heaven holds some kind of grudge against me.'

"Is everything okay, Senior?" Yu Rou asked him after seeing his dejected expression.

"Although you may not have amazing talents, you should be able to live a comfortable life with the Pure Yin Physique. Good luck, young lady." The old man said to her before disappearing into the cracked space behind him.

A few seconds after the old man left, Yu Rou felt her consciousness being transported to another place, and she could see a large crowd of people standing around her when she opened her eyes again.

"Welcome to the world of Cultivation, Mortals!"

A loud and clear voice resounded above Yu Rou, causing her and the other people there to look up at the sky, where a handsome middle-aged man was floating in the air and staring down at them with a smile on his face.

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Chapter 56 - Leaving Pang City

"I am Elder Yang, and I will be giving you a brief introduction to our world before I let you explore this vast world by yourself," said the handsome middle-aged man floating in the sky.

"First and foremost, you should know about the existence of Cultivators, as we have the potential to become the most powerful beings in this world, even becoming a God. I am what you call a Cultivator, and as Cultivators, we absorb the energy of Heaven and Earth that are known as Qi or Spiritual Energy to cultivate our bodies. Once you've cultivated enough, you can do things like fly around the skies like a bird with wings or even split the seas with your fist."

"The next thing you should keep in mind is that in the cultivation world strength is all that matters. In a world where the strong eat the weak, if you do not have the power to defend yourself, you are essentially a chicken waiting to be hunted by the strong, and you can blame nobody but yourselves when that happens."

"Now that you know the basics of this world, allow me to bestow you the method of cultivation. Of course, this cultivation technique is only the most basic one out there. If you wish to obtain a stronger cultivation method, you must find it yourself in this vast world."

With a single wave of his sleeves, every player there received the skill 'Basic Qi Gathering Technique'.

"And before I send you all away, do any of you have either a Heaven-rank or Earth-rank Physique?" Elder Yang looked at the Players with an anticipating gaze.

Yu Rou looked at her own status.

«Pure Yin Physique»

«Rank: Earth»

"I have an Earth-ranked Physique called the Pure Yin Physique," she said as she raised her hand.

"Oh, the Pure Yin Physique, huh?" Elder Yang looked at Yu Rou while nodding his head with approval.

"Although it may only be Earth-ranked, the Pure Yin Physique is at the top of most Physiques at that rank, even beating some Heaven-rank Physique in terms of usefulness. As for what it does— it simply allows you to absorb Spiritual Energy or Qi that contains Yin Elements much easier than normal people. Furthermore, your body will dispose of all impurities for you, saving you the effort of needing to dispose of them by yourself. If you ever manage to reach the Higher Heaven, visit the Divine Yin Temple. They will gladly accept someone like you as their disciple, and don't forget to mention that Elder Yang from the Supreme Yang Temple referred you to them."

Yu Rou nodded at the Cultivator's words.

"Nobody else has either a Heaven-ranked or Earth-ranked Physique? What a disappointing bunch." Elder Yang shook his head in a disappointed manner before waving his sleeves again, sending the Players towards the teleporters right behind them.

"..."

Yu Rou opened her eyes again, finding herself in the middle of a busy city this time around.

"Where is this?"

Yu Rou proceeded to walk around the city for a few minutes, even asking the pedestrians about their location.

"This is the Spring City in the Eastern Continent," said one of the pedestrians.

"I see. Thank you."

Now that Yu Rou was aware of her location, she continued to explore the city and experience the beauty of this world for a few more minutes before logging off and going to sleep.

However, she did not fall asleep right away like usual, as the world of Cultivation Online had left a deep impression, filling her heart with excitement.

'I cannot wait to explore this world with Brother...' she thought to herself before falling asleep after much effort.

"..."

"..."

"..."

"Brother, are you awake?" Yu Rou entered his room early in the morning.

"Yes, I am. Did you enter the game last night?" he asked her.

"I did! And I was blown away by how amazing and realistic the world seemed! It exceeded my expectations on many levels! No wonder why it's the most popular game in the entire world right now! I almost didn't want to log off once I started playing!" Yu Rou spoke in a voice filled with excitement, sounding like a child who just went to the amusement park for the first time.

"Hahaha... So you finally understand..." Yuan said with a smile on his face.

"Anyway, after getting my character evaluated, I was given a brief explanation about the world by some Cultivator before being sent to this beginner's city called 'Spring City' in the Eastern Continent. I don't know how far away it is from Pang City, but I hope it's not too far."

"Don't worry, Yu Rou. No matter how far away you are, I will come to you. Spring City, right? I will definitely see you there."

"Un! I can't wait to play with you, Brother!" Yu Rou nodded with enthusiasm.

Sometime later, Yu Rou went to prepare for school whilst Yuan returned to the game.

"Welcome back, Brother Yuan." Xiao Hua said to him after seeing his face appear out of thin air like a ghost.

"Did anything happen while I was away?" he asked her.

"Luo Ling and Luo Li came to visit you last night, but I told them you had to go somewhere," she said to him.

"I see. Let's go talk to them now before we leave this place."

Xiao Hua nodded and followed him to meet with the Luo Family.

"Luo Li!" Yuan called out to her after seeing her figure in the hallway.

"Brother Yuan, you're back." Luo Li greeted him with a courteous bow.

"Sorry I missed you last night. I had to log off for the night."

"Don't worry about it. It wasn't anything important, anyway." Luo Li said to him with a slightly rosy face when she recalled the reason she visited him last night.

"Anyway, I was just about to call you for breakfast," she then said to him.

Yuan nodded and said, "Let's go. I need to fill my stomach before I return to my journey."

"You're leaving already?" Luo Li looked at him with a dispirited face. Although she knew that this moment would eventually come, she didn't

want to part with him so soon, as there were still many things that she wanted to do with him.

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Chapter 57 - Teleportation Device

"Yes, I plan on leaving this place after breakfast," said Yuan after Luo Li asked about his departure.

"Is that so... I understand." Luo Li nodded before continuing, "Let's continue this conversation with everyone else."

"Okay."

Sometime later, Yuan and the Luo Family began eating breakfast.

"Where do you plan on going after this, Brother Yuan? Or are you still planning on going to the Purple Bamboo Forest for training?" Luo Ling asked him during breakfast. While they normally speak after breakfast, she didn't want to waste any more time after learning that he would be leaving soon.

"No, my plans have changed. I will be going to Spring City after this to meet up with someone. As for training at Purple Bamboo Forest... that will have to wait until a later date."

"Spring City? That's quite far away from here even if you are flying there on a sword." Lord Luo said to him.

"Really? How far is it?" Yuan asked him with a slightly anxious frown, worried that he might not be able to meet Yu Rou on time.

"Spring City is approximately 30 thousand miles from our Pang City. It will take you over 100 hours to fly there even if you flew without rest for the entire journey."

"No way..." Yuan's face immediately dropped after learning just how far away Spring City was from his current location. At this rate, Yu Rou's entire vacation will end by the time he even gets there, and he will have to wait another week before they can play together.

Seeing the desperation on Yuan's face, Luo Ming spoke out loud, "If you are in that much of a hurry to get to Spring City, why don't you use the Teleportation Device in Liang City? It's only 3,000 miles from here. Though, you will have to pay a tremendous amount of gold to use it."

"Really? I can reach Spring City in a short amount of time if I use this Teleportation Device?!" Yuan's dispirited expression immediately brightened.

"Yes, you should be able to reach Spring City before the day ends. However, it won't be cheap. After all, Teleportation Devices require a massive amount of spiritual energy to operate, and the further you need to go, the more expensive it'll cost you. 30,000 miles isn't bad at all, so the gold we gave you should be more than enough for you to use it." Luo Ming said to him.

"Thank you! I will use this Teleportation Device even if it'll cost me an arm and leg!" Yuan said to him.

"Why are you in such a hurry, Brother Yuan? Is this person you are meeting that important?" Luo Ling suddenly asked him.

"Yes, she's the most important person in my life!" He responded without hesitation.

"The most important person in your life...?" Luo Li repeated in a low voice, feeling somewhat envious of this person.

Even Xiao Hua couldn't help but look at him with her interest piqued.

"It's not an exaggeration to say if not for her, I would not be alive right now." Yuan nodded with a heartfelt expression on his face.

"Is she your lover, Brother Yuan?" Luo Ming couldn't help but ask him.

"Hahaha... of course, not." Yuan laughed at his words before saying, "She's my sister."

'Oh, it's just his sister...' The Luo Family sighed in relief after hearing his words.

"Brother Yuan's sister... what kind of person is she?" Xiao Hua suddenly asked him while staring at him intensively.

"She's a very kind individual who puts others' well-being above her own. Even though she's already busy enough with her own life, she never fails to take care of me every single day, even when she's exhausted herself, and I cannot thank her enough for her sacrifices."

"It sounds like you have a wonderful sister, Brother Yuan. I fully understand why you must leave now." Luo Li said to him with a smile.

Once the small conversation was over, they continued to eat.

Sometime later, once breakfast was finished, Lord Luo whispered to one of the servants.

The servant returned a few minutes later with a scroll in her hands and handed it to Yuan.

"That map will show you how to get to Liang City from here. Since you will be flying, it will be much easier for you, but you must pass a mountain range before you can see Liang City."

"Thank you," Yuan accepted the map.

"Allow me to walk you outside, Brother Yuan." Luo Ling stood up and said to him.

"I will come too." Luo Li also said.

A few moments later, Luo Ling suddenly embraced one of his arms close to her chest whilst Luo Li went for the other before leading him outside, making Yuan appear to be some kind of playboy with a beauty in each of his arms.

Once they were outside, Yuan was dumbfounded by the massive crowd that filled the streets.

"W-Why is there so many people here?" he was dumbfounded.

"After what happened with the Mountain Lord, our Pang City has been flooded with visitors. Many of them appeared to have come here looking for Brother Yuan, and even though we have already told them that you had long left this city, the numbers continued to grow." Luo Ling said to him.

"I see... then I can only fly out of here..." Yuan sighed.

"Goodbye, Luo Li, Luo Ling. I won't forget my experience here." He then said to them with a bright smile on his face.

"Can I hug you before you leave?" Luo Li suddenly asked him.

Yuan nodded and opened his arms without thinking too much about it.

Luo Li immediately leaped into his arms and embraced him tightly. "Come back here when you have the time, okay? I will always be waiting for you."

"I will."

After hugging him for a few moments, Luo Li released her arms and took a step back before suddenly propelling herself towards Yuan, kissing him on the cheeks.

"..."

Yuan was speechless, but he didn't mind it.

"I will see you later, Brother Yuan..." Luo Li said to him with a red face before running back into the house.

"It's my turn to say goodbye." Luo Ling also went to embrace him.

"I am going to miss you," she mumbled to him.

A few moments later, Luo Ling released him and kissed him on the other side of his cheeks, and unlike Luo Li, she did not immediately run away afterward.

"The next time you visit us, we can do something even more intimate," she winked at him in a seductive manner.

Although Yuan couldn't understand the meaning behind her words, he nodded his head regardless.

"I will see you later," he said to her.

Once Luo Ling also entered the house, Xiao Hua said to him, "Brother Yuan sure is popular with the ladies."

"Hehe..." he showed a bashful smile before speaking, "Anyway, let's head to Liang City for the Teleportation Device."

Yuan then retrieved his Spirit Sword to let Xiao Hua control it. A few moments later, the two of them soared towards the clear sky and left the city, shocking the people that saw them from below.

Chapter 58 - Liang City

After leaving Pang City, Yuan and Xiao Hua flew straight towards Liang City. However, because of Yuan's low cultivation base, they needed multiple breaks in between their journey.

"I am going to eat the Mountain Lord's monster core now," Yuan suddenly said during their third break.

A few moments later, he popped the monster core into his mouth like a piece of candy before swallowing the sweetness.

«Heaven Refining Physique activated»

«311,000,000 Qi has been refined from the Black Beast's Monster Core»

307,680,000/307,680,000

«You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough»

«You have reached the Fifth Level Spirit Warrior»

«+3,000 Stats»

480,500,000/615,360,000

After consuming the Mountain Lord's Monster Core, Yuan could feel his exhausted energy instantly recover to the brim and more.

He then turned to look at his status screen.

Cultivation: Fifth Level Spirit Warrior

Legacy: None

Bloodline: None

Physique: Heaven Refining Physique

Physical Strength: 12,734

Mental Strength: 12,975

Soul Strength: 14,910

Physical Defense: 12,710

Mental Defense: 13,821

Qi Experience: 480,500,000/615,360,000

Fame: 80

Charm: 30

Luck: 10

Seeing these large numbers, Yuan couldn't help but wonder if it was normal for Cultivators at his level to have such high stats.

He then looked at his available skills.

«Heaven's Secret Art» «Mastery Level: 2»

«Consuming Heaven Technique» «Mastery Level: 2»

«Heaven Splitting Sword Strike» «Mastery Level: 2»

«Bloody Sword Strike» «Mastery Level: 3»

«Thousand Knife Technique» «Mastery Level: 1»

«Heavenly Fire Control» «Mastery Level: 1»

«Cooking Skill» «Mastery Level: 1»

«Advanced Senses»

«Enhanced Strength»

«Weak Poison Resistance»

«Novice Sword Mastery»

Despite having so many techniques at hand, Yuan felt like he only had one or two from using the same technique over and over again. However, it was not as though there was any need for him to use the other techniques when Bloody Sword Strike is more than enough to handle most threats with ease.

"Are you okay, Brother Yuan?" Xiao Hua asked him in a worried tone after noticing that he had been staring at the empty air with a dazed face, worrying that he might have finally gone crazy from eating too many monster cores.

"Oh, I'm fine. I was just thinking about something," he said a moment later.

"Anyway, let's continue our journey now that I am full of energy again."

Xiao Hua nodded, and they returned to the sky shortly later.

"..."

"..."

"..."

"Do we need to rest again?" Xiao Hua asked him an hour later.

Yuan shook his head and spoke in a relaxed tone, "No, I am still filled with energy. I cannot believe how much stronger I got just from one level."

"The higher your cultivation, the more difference between each level." Xiao Hua said to him.

After flying for another hour, Yuan was finally beginning to feel tired, so they rested for half an hour, and they continued this routine until they reached Liang City.

"Finally... I can finally see the city!" Yuan spoke with teary eyes when he saw the tall city walls in the distance. It has been over 12 hours since they left Pang City, and the entire journey was simply mentally exhausting for someone like Yuan who has never traveled such a long distance in one go before.

Sometime later, they descended near the entrance where there was a decently long queue of people waiting to get inside the city.

However, when the guards saw how Yuan and Xiao Hua appeared out of nowhere from the skies, they immediately ignored the people in the line and rushed towards them.

"Welcome to our Liang City, Senior Cultivators. If there's anything you need, please let us assist you." The guards spoke after politely bowing to them.

"We're here for the Teleportation Device," said Yuan. "It's here, right?"

"That is correct. Our Liang City indeed has a Teleportation Device. However, it has a travel distance limit of 70,000 miles."

"That's more than enough. I only intend on traveling to Spring City, which should be around 30,000 miles away."

"I understand. Please come with me, I will lead you to the Teleportation Device."

Yuan nodded and followed one of the guards into the city while the other guards returned to assist the other people.

Sometime later, they reached the center of Liang City, where the Teleportation Device was in the middle of a crowded square street.

"That's the Teleportation Device?" Yuan raised his eyebrows in a surprised manner after seeing the large circular object that seemed to be made of some kind of metallic material. It looked like a massive round mirror but without the glass in the middle, and there was even a stage right before it.

"Is there anything else you need from me, Seniors?" The guard asked them after they arrived.

"No, this is all... Thank you for taking the time to bring us here." Yuan said to him.

"Please, you don't even need to mention it. I am merely doing my job."

The guard left a few moments later, leaving Yuan and Xiao Hua standing before the Teleportation Device.

"Where would you like to go?" An old man with a profound aura standing beside the Teleportation Device suddenly spoke to Yuan after noticing their presence.

"Spring City," he said.

"Spring City, huh. That would be 30,247 miles from here." The old man said to him.

"How much will it cost?"

"350,000 gold coins." The old man quickly responded.

'That much?!' Yuan cried inwardly. Although he had prepared himself for it, the price still shocked him greatly.

Seeing Yuan's dumbfounded expression, the old man said, "It requires an enormous amount of spiritual energy to operate the Teleportation Device; it's only natural it'll cost this much."

"Do you still want to use it?"

Yuan quickly nodded, "Yes, I do."

The old man then extended his wrinkly hands towards Yuan, signaling him for the payment.

Seeing this, Yuan sighed inwardly before taking out his storage pouch and handing the old man the money.

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Chapter 59 - Xuan Family

After counting the money with his spiritual sense, the old man nodded with satisfaction and said to them, "Go ahead and step onto the stage."

Yuan and Xiao Hua proceeded to walk onto the stage and stood before the massive Teleportation Device.

The old man then walked to a stand that was only a few meters away and placed onto it a few chunks of beautiful crystal that emitted intense spiritual energy.

A few moments later, once the Teleportation Device was charged up with Spirit Qi from the crystals, the empty space before Yuan began to twist and turn, and a black portal appeared.

"You won't be directly teleported inside Spring City but a few miles out. Enter the Teleportation Device whenever you are ready but don't take too long because it will disappear in a minute."

Yuan nodded and turned to look at Xiao Hua.

"Are you ready?" He asked her.

"Whenever Brother Yuan is ready," she nodded her small head.

Yuan then extended his hand for her to hold, and Xiao Hua grabbed it without hesitation.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan took a step forward and walked into the portal while holding Xiao Hua's small hands, disappearing from Liang City.

And literally a second later, just like when he first entered the game and met Xiao Hua, Yuan found himself surrounded by trees in the middle of nowhere.

"Let's go up," Yuan said, and they soared to the sky a moment later to look for the city.

"I think it's that place over there," Yuan pointed at the city in the distance.

"Let's go."

They began flying towards the city.

«You have discovered 'Spring City'»

A few minutes later, they descended from the sky and landed in front of the city gates, and just like the guards from Pang City and Liang City, the guards at Spring City immediately approached them after seeing them descend from the Heavens.

"Welcome to our Spring City, Seniors. If you need anything, just let me know." The guard said to him.

"It's fine. We are only here to meet with someone." Yuan said to the guard.

"May I have the Seniors name so we can report to the Xuan Family of your presence?" The guard suddenly said.

"Xuan Family?" Yuan suddenly recalled Xuan Wuhan, who mentioned that her family was in this city.

"That's correct, Senior. The Xuan Family controls this city, and we were instructed to let them know if any experts arrive at our city to avoid any unnecessary trouble." The guard explained to him.

"Then do you know Xuan Wuhan?" Yuan asked him.

"The Young Lady? Are you acquainted with the Young Lady?" The guard showed a surprised face.

"Yes, she asked me to see her if I ever visit Spring City, and I have some time before my meeting. Here, she even gave me this."

Yuan showed him the medallion Xuan Wuhan gave him in Spirit City.

"That's the Xuan Family's Medallion!" The guards' eyes widened with surprise after seeing the medallion. Only those trusted by the Xuan Family would have something like that!

"Please follow me, esteemed guests! I will immediately bring you to the Xuan Family!" The guard bowed to them with respect.

"By the way, you can call me Yuan."

"Young Master Yuan!"

Meanwhile, another guard rushed to return to the Xuan Family before Yuan and Xiao Hua could arrive to alert them about their presence.

"What? Someone with my family's medallion is coming here? I don't recall anyone that goes by the name 'Yuan'." The head of the Xuan Family, Patriarch Xuan raised his eyebrows after hearing about Yuan.

"He mentioned the Young Lady's name, even claiming that she was the one who gave him the medallion," said the guard.

Patriarch Xuan nodded and said, "Bring my daughter here."

"Yes, Patriarch!"

Sometime later, Xuan Wuhan appeared before them with a messy appearance, looking like she'd just gotten out of bed.

"What's the matter, father? I was having a nice dream, you know?" she asked him with a tired expression.

"Do you know someone by the name of 'Yuan'?" Patriarch Xuan immediately asked her.

"How do you know about Daoist Yuan, father?" Xuan Wuhan's face immediately became energetic after hearing Yuan's name, and she looked at him with a surprised face.

"So you are acquainted with him?"

"Yes, I met him at Spirit City and the auction house there. Although I don't know his background, he's definitely not an ordinary individual, especially the little girl who follows him around. I have a feeling that she's a real expert like Grandpa."

"A Spirit Master like my father, huh? That's very likely, as the guards saw her flying with their own eyes."

"Wait a moment! They were here? In our city?!" Xuan Wuhan quickly asked him.

"Yes, and they are heading here as we speak."

"Why didn't you tell me that from the beginning! I am not ready to receive any guests, and I have already wasted plenty of time here!"

"Then you'd best hurry up and fix your appearance before they arrive." Patriarch Xuan shook his head at her. While Xuan Wuhan is known for being a hard worker by the people outside, she was the complete opposite at home, being a lazy girl who spends most of her time sleeping.

"I will be right back!" Xuan Wuhan said before she ran towards the bathroom.

Meanwhile, Yuan and Xiao Hua had just arrived at the Xuan Family's household.

"Heavens... This place is even bigger than the Luo Family's manor in Pang City. It's almost like comparing a small hut to a massive mansion!" Yuan spoke with a dazed look on his face as he stood right outside their building. It's no wonder why Xuan Wuhan was treated like a V.I.P at the auction house.

"The Xuan Family has already been notified of your arrival, esteemed guests."

Just as the guard finished his sentence, the door opened, and a handsome and tall middle-aged man with a profound aura walked out of the building and stared at Yuan with a sharp gaze.

'Fifth Level Spirit Warrior?! How old is this young man? He doesn't look any older than my daughter!' Patriarch Xuan was filled with surprise after seeing his cultivation base and young appearance.

However, what shocked him the most was Xiao Hua's formidable presence, who was naturally emitting a profound aura, yet he could not see the full extent of her cultivation base despite being a Spirit Master himself.

'A real expert! She's a real expert!' he cried inwardly.

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Chapter 60 - What The Heck Happened To You?!

"You must be Daoist Yuan. I am the Patriarch of the Xuan Family and Xuan Wuhan's father, Xuan Chao. Thank you for taking the time to visit our humble family." Patriarch Xuan clasped his hands together and bowed to them respectfully with a friendly smile on his face.

"Thank you for having me." Yuan followed his movements and returned the bow.

"Please, come inside."

Yuan and Xiao Hua then followed him into the massive building.

"Welcome, Esteemed Guests."

Two rows of servants standing parallel to each other bowed to them in unison as they entered the house.

Once they were in the guest room, the servants served them tea, and Patriarch Xuan spoke as Yuan held the teacup, "I have heard about you from my daughter, Daoist Yuan, and I must say, you are as talented as... No, you have exceeded my expectations. Reaching the Fifth Level Spirit Warrior realm at such a young age, I can only imagine how talented your Master must be."

"And I cannot help but ask, just how old are you this year?" Patriarch Xuan looked at him with clear eyes filled with interest.

"I turned 18 three months ago," Yuan responded casually.

"E-E-Eighteen?!" Patriarch Xuan exclaimed, nearly standing up from shock. Although Yuan looked young, he did not really expect him to be such a young man since appearance is the most deceptive part about Cultivators with Xiao Hua as the perfect example.

"Unbelievable... I thought you were near my daughter's age, maybe even slightly older, but alas, to think you were actually younger than her by 3 years!" Patriarch Xuan praised him without feeling any shame, even feeling a little envious of his talent.

And while he wanted to ask Yuan about his background, Patriarch Xuan did not want to appear too inquisitive on their first meeting.

It was at this moment the door to the room opened, and a beautiful young lady wearing subtle yet striking makeup entered the room.

Yuan turned around to look at Xuan Wuhan and smiled upon seeing her, "Hello, Xuan Wuhan. I have come to visit you."

"Daoist Yuan! Thank you for— What the heck happened to you?!"

Xuan Wuhan suddenly exclaimed in a shocked tone midway through her sentence, dumbfounding Yuan and Patriarch Xuan.

"Eh?" Yuan watched with wide eyes as Xuan Wuhan ran towards him in an aggressive manner.

"How are you already at the Fifth Level Spirit Warrior realm?! The last time I saw you, you were only at the first level! And that was only a few days ago!" she looked at him with a gawking face.

"What!?" Patriarch Xuan stood up from shock after hearing his daughter's baffling words. Not even a cultivating monster can improve their cultivation so quickly! Just what kind of background does Yuan have?

"W-Well... A few things have occurred since the auction house..." Yuan said with a weird smile on his face.

"You must've had quite the fortunate encounter to raise your cultivation so quickly. How envious. I also want a fortunate encounter..." Xuan Wuhan sighed loudly.

"I wouldn't call them fortunate events, though..." Yuan shook his head with a bitter smile.

"Anyway, what brings you to Spring City? Don't tell me you are here just to see me?" she asked him with flickering eyes.

"I'm meeting with my sister here," Yuan calmly responded.

"Oh..." Xuan Wuhan mumbled, feeling somewhat disappointed.

"Then how long do you plan on staying here?" she asked a moment later.

"I'm not sure, but it probably won't be long," he said.

"Do you have a place to stay? If not, you can stay here for the time being. We have plenty of guest rooms."

"That probably won't be necessary, since I will be meeting with my sister in a few hours. Thank you for the offering, though."

"Don't worry. If you ever need a place to stay, you know where to go," she said to him.

"What about dinner? It's being prepared right now," Patriarch Xuan suddenly said.

"I can stay for that." Yuan nodded.

While they waited for dinner to be ready, Xuan Wuhan asked Yuan about his activities after they separated from the auction house.

Yuan then told them about his encounter with the Demonic Spider and the Mountain Lord at Pang City.

Both Xuan Wuhan and Patriarch Xuan listened to his adventure with dropping jaws. How can so much happen in just a few days? Furthermore, it doesn't explain how he managed to improve his cultivation base so quickly.

"You said that you don't belong to any sect, right? Do you intend on joining one in the future?" Xuan Wuhan asked him afterward.

"I honestly don't know. I haven't seen enough of this world yet to want to stay in one place for an extended amount of time," he said.

"If that is your only concern then I don't think you need to worry because only the newer disciples have their movements and activities limited to within the Sect, mostly for their own safety." Xuan Wuhan said, and she continued, "Inner Disciples and Core Disciples such as myself have plenty of freedom. In fact, most of us spend more time outside than inside the sect."

"Take me for example. I belong to a sect, yet I spend more time outside than at the sect. As long as I don't slack and continue to progress my cultivation, they won't restrict my movements."

"And with your talents and your current cultivation, it's almost guaranteed that you will become a Core Disciple the instant you join a sect. If you are still worried, then you can join my sect. My grandfather is an Elder at the sect, and with his backing, even the Sect Leader will have to think twice before doing anything to you."

Hearing her words, Yuan nodded and said, "I will think about it."

Although he wasn't interested in Sects at first, if he wants to have a better understanding of Cultivators, he should live around them for some time. And since Xuan Wuhan has reassured him that he won't have his freedom limited, it seemed like the perfect time to join one.

However, because he still needed his sister's opinion on this matter, he won't make any decisions for now.

Chapter 61 - Meeting With Yu Rou

"Take as long as you need to think about it. Although it's very common for Cultivators to join a Sect, it's not something you should take lightly, as it will more likely than not affect the rest of your life." Xuan Wuhan said to him.

"And if you ever decide to join a Sect, come to the Dragon Essence Temple. It's one of the top Sects in the world and also where I am currently. They'll treat you nicely—I can guarantee you that."

Yuan nodded, "I will keep that in mind."

Sometime later, once dinner was ready, Xiao Hua asked Yuan after they were seated at the dining table, "Are you going to be okay with so little food, Brother Yuan?"

Because the Xuan Family is not aware of Yuan's eating habits, she was worried that the food might not even fill the gap between his teeth.

"Although it won't be enough to fill my stomach, I don't need a full stomach every time I eat something," he said a moment later.

Xiao Hua no longer said anything and they began eating shortly later.

Many minutes later, after dinner, Yuan said to the Xuan Family, "Thank you for the wonderful dinner. I have to go now."

"You're leaving already? It's already dark outside." Xuan Wuhan said to him, seemingly reluctant to see him leave so quickly.

"I would like to stay for longer, but my sister should be arriving soon, and I have promised her that I won't make her wait for long."

"Is that so..." Xuan Wuhan nodded and said, "Then promise me that you'll come to visit me again in the future."

She then extended her hand to him like she was asking for a handshake.

Yuan did not hesitate to shake her hands and said, "I promise."

Once Yuan and Xiao Hua left the building a few moments later, Patriarch Xuan said to her, "You really like him, huh? I have never seen you act so friendly towards another man before."

"Even though he's extremely talented and powerful, it isn't obvious at glance, and that doesn't change even after you speak with him. He's a very kind and humble individual despite his status— completely opposite of the arrogant geniuses that I am used to seeing on a daily basis. It's a refreshing feeling." Xuan Wuhan said with a gentle smile on her face.

"I cannot argue with that. Talented Cultivators like him are very rare nowadays. They are usually filled with arrogance, and the more talented they are the worse their character. It only makes one wonder what kind of background he's from." Patriarch Xuan nodded in an approving manner.

"Why don't you go talk to your grandfather? Let him know about the situation and see if he can convince Daoist Yuan to join the Sect." He suddenly suggested.

However, Xuan Wuhan shook her head and said, "I will let grandpa know about his existence, but I won't tell him to convince Daoist Yuan. We can't look desperate, after all."

Meanwhile, outside the building, Yuan said to Xiao Hua, "I am going to log off for now."

"See you later, Brother Yuan." Xiao Hua said to him before disappearing into the necklace.

A few moments later, Yuan left the cultivation world and proceeded to wait for Yu Rou to return in the real world.

"Brother! I am back! I can finally play with you tomorrow!" Yu Rou's excited voice resounded outside his room, and Yuan could hear the sound of her running in the hallway.

"Welcome back, Yu Rou," Yuan said to her with a smile on his face after she entered his room a moment later.

"Un! Let me change out of my school uniform and prepare dinner for you first! I will be right back!" Yu Rou said to him, and she ran outside before Yuan could even tell her to calm down.

About half an hour later, Yu Rou returned to his room with all of the necessities on a small cart.

"How was your day, Brother? Do you think you'll be able to make it to Spring City by tomorrow morning?" Yu Rou asked him as she wiped his skinny body with a warm wet towel.

"You have underestimated me, Yu Rou. I am already in Spring City." Yuan responded with a smile.

"Really? I bet you were already close to it." Yu Rou said, completely unaware that he'd traveled over 30,000 miles and spent 350,000 gold coins just to get there.

"You have no idea..." Yuan said.

"And what do you mean tomorrow morning? Can you not play tonight?"

"I would love to play tonight, but I have piano practice at home early tomorrow morning, so I have to sleep right after this," she said as she changed the wet towel and wiped his body for the second time.

"I see... then I will also sleep early tonight to make time pass by faster," Yuan said.

After cleaning and feeding Yuan, Yu Rou went to shower and eat her own dinner before going to sleep, not even bothering to spend a few minutes on the internet as usual.

The following morning, Yu Rou woke up early and spent 2 hours with piano practice before returning to Yuan's room to wash his face and feed him breakfast.

"Let's meet at the front of the city by the entrance," Yu Rou said to Yuan as she wiped his lips after breakfast.

"Sounds good. I will see you there." Yuan said.

A few minutes later, Yuan entered the game while Yu Rou returned to her own room.

"Xiao Hua, let's go. We're going to meet my sister now."

"Un." Xiao Hua nodded her head, feeling slightly nervous for some reason.

"By the way, can you do me a favor?" Yuan suddenly asked her as they walked to the front of the city.

"What is it, Brother Yuan?" she looked at him.

"Can you not call me 'Yuan' when we are with my sister? I'd like to surprise her later," he said.

Xiao Hua tilted her head with a puzzled expression on her face after hearing his words.

"It's a bit complicated, but my real name is not really Yuan... I mean, it is, but it isn't at the same time," he revealed to her.

Chapter 62 - Yu Tian

"Then what should Xiao Hua call Brother Yuan?" she asked him.

"Tian... Yu Tian, that is my real name," Yuan said to her.

"Xiao Hua understands, Brother Tian," she nodded her head.

"Thank you, Xiao Hua."

Yuan and Xiao Hua continued to approach the city's entrance.

Many minutes later, they arrived at the city gate, and to their surprise, there was a small crowd gathered there and looking like they were surrounding something, and they were all young men.

"Fairy lady, what is your name? I am Bai Chen from the Heavenly Tiger Academy..."

"Forget about him, young fairy. My father is an Elder at the prestigious Nine Crane Sect!"

"Why are you standing here by yourself, young lady? Are you waiting for someone? Why don't you come with me instead—"

A clear and delightful-sounding voice suddenly interrupted these young men, "I am sorry, but I have no interest in accompanying any of you, and I already have a schedule with someone else."

"Are you saying this person you are waiting for is more important than me, Yin Zhou, Inner Disciple of the mighty Jade Fist Mountain!?" An arrogant voice resounded afterward.

"That's right." The feminine voice responded, sounding as calm as a still pond, "This person is more important to me than anything else in the world."

"This voice belongs to..." Yuan could instantly recognize this beautiful voice even if she mumbled a single word with a thousand people talking loudly around her.

"The audacity! I don't care if you have a pretty face, but how dare you slap my face before my fellow disciples—"

"Yu Rou!" Yuan shouted her name as he approached the crowd.

"Brother...?" Yu Rou's eyes flickered brightly after hearing his voice. Although it sounded clearer and more energetic than usual, she would never mistake his voice for another's.

"Who the hell are you?" The crowd around Yu Rou immediately turned their attention to Yuan with frowns, who wore a calm on his face.

"Oh? Are you perhaps the person she's waiting for— the person that's more important than me? Then you have exactly three seconds to turn around and leave before I—"

Before the man could even finish his sentence, Yuan took a step forward and swung his sword at a speed that could not be followed with one's eyes, stopping directly before the man's neck.

"I don't care who you are— You have three seconds to leave her alone before I send you to hell," Yuan spoke in a cold and demanding voice, his gaze filled with a dreadful feeling that threatened to destroy anything that dares to disobey his command.

Feeling the cold blade pressing against his neck, the man named Yin Zhou didn't even dare to swallow.

'This young man is in the fifth level Spirit Warrior realm! He's definitely a genius disciple from a renowned sect! I cannot mess with him!' Yin Zhou

cried inwardly after sensing the powerful aura emitting from Yuan's body.

"T-There must have been a misunderstanding, Young Master... I will immediately leave..."

Once the disciples from the Jade Fist Mountain left, the others also left in silence, not daring to offend this mysterious expert that came out of nowhere.

'Brother Yuan...' Xiao Hua was dumbfounded by the fierceness shown by Yuan just now, as this is her first time seeing him emit killing intent towards another human being. In fact, she didn't even know he could be this domineering.

When the path between the siblings was cleared and Yu Rou could finally see the tall and handsome young man that stood not too far away from her, she covered her mouth from shock, and her eyes flickered with many emotions simultaneously, causing it to become teary.

"You are taller than I'd anticipated, Yu Rou..." Yuan spoke with a warm smile on his face, his gaze at the beautiful young lady before him.

"Brother Tian... You... I..." Yu Rou was speechless. Even though she'd prepared in advance what she wanted to say to him, after seeing her brother who had been crippled for nearly his entire life standing and looking completely healthy, she was simply at a loss for words.

"What's wrong, Yu Rou? Why aren't you saying anything? Cat's got your tongue?" Yuan said to her after waiting long enough.

"Brother Tian! Waaaa!"

In response to his words, Yu Rou lunged herself at him with her arms wide open while crying out loud, "I cannot believe it... you... you look even better than I'd imagined you would if you were healthy!"

Yuan immediately opened his arms to catch her in his embrace before hugging her tightly, something he has been wanting to do for many years

but was not physically capable of. However, with Cultivation Online's 100% immersive system, it finally allowed Yuan to feel Yu Rou's warmth, and it allowed Yu Rou's dream to witness Yuan being healthy again to come true.

And albeit they were only inside a game and not in the real world, it still meant a great deal to them.

"Yes... you also look a lot different than I'd imagined," Yuan said to her.

A few minutes later, once Yu Rou cried enough and calmed down, Yuan said to her, "Let me introduce you to my little friend who has been with me since the beginning and helped me a great deal since then. It wouldn't be an exaggeration to say that if not for her, I wouldn't be here right now. I have said this before but she's like another little sister to me now."

"..."

Yu Rou turned to look at the pretty young girl standing behind Yuan.

'What a pretty girl! She looks just like a doll!' Yu Rou was surprised by Xiao Hua's doll-like appearance. There's no doubt that Xiao Hua would grow up to be a very beautiful woman.

"Nice to meet you, Brother Tian's sister. Xiao Hua is Xiao Hua," she introduced herself a moment later.

"She's an NPC, right? Why is she talking in third-person?" Yu Rou asked Yuan.

"Is that weird? I find it very cute," Yuan said.

"Cute..." Yu Rou looked at him with slightly narrowed eyes.

"Anyways, I am called Yu Rou. Since Brother Tian treats you like a little sister, let's try to get along, okay?" Yu Rou extended her hands towards Xiao Hua for a handshake.

Xiao Hua nodded and shook her hands, yet there was this fierce atmosphere between the two of them, almost like they were standing on an invisible battlefield.

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Chapter 63 - Cultivators“ Haven

After shaking hands with Xiao Hua, Yu Rou turned to look at Yuan's handsome appearance some more, almost as though she was trying to engrave his image into her soul.

"Anyway, now that we are together, what do you want to do, Yu Rou?" Yuan asked her a moment later.

"I haven't really thought about it, but I would like to raise my cultivation a little bit first. I don't want to be a burden, after all."

"You don't have to worry about that since I will never see you as a burden. In fact, I would like you to rely on me, as I can only do something for you in this world." Yuan said to her.

"Thank you, Brother..." she nodded.

"Xiao Hua, are there any quiet places we can go so she can cultivate peacefully?" Yuan then asked her.

"We can rent a cultivation room," she quickly said. "They are made specifically for these kinds of situations where Cultivators need a place to cultivate in peace but do not have a place of their own."

"A cultivation room...? That sounds very interesting," Yu Rou said. "Where can we find one?"

"There are at least one in every city, so there should be one here too."

"Let's ask around." Yuan suggested.

A few minutes later, after speaking with some of the pedestrians, they learned of a place called 'Cultivators' Haven' that was only a few blocks away, so they began making their way towards that place.

Sometime later, they stood before a large and tall building that had over twenty floors, resembling a pagoda.

Once they entered the building, one of the receptionists there noticed them and immediately waved her hands at them.

"Welcome to Cultivators' Haven! How may I assist you?" The beautiful lady asked them once they approached her.

"Hello, we would like to rent a room for cultivation." Yuan responded.

The receptionist looked at them and asked, "One room for each of you or just one room?"

"One room is fine," he said.

"Then how long would you like to rent the room for?"

Yuan turned to look at Yu Rou and asked her, "How long?"

"I don't want to spend too much time on cultivation when I am with you so a few hours is enough," Yu Rou said.

Yuan nodded and returned to the receptionist, "Four hours is enough."

However, the receptionist responded with an apologetic expression, "I'm sorry, but we cannot rent the room for less than 24 hours at a time. Though, you can leave at any time you want."

"Okay, then we'll do 24 hours." Yuan nodded.

"Thank you. Now as for the room itself, which floor would you like a room in?"

"What's the difference?" Yuan asked.

"We have a total of 21 rooms available in our Cultivators' Haven, and the higher floor you go, the more effective your cultivation will be since we have placed special arrays to improve the quality of Spirit Qi in that room. Of course, it all comes at a higher cost."

"The rooms on floors 1 to 9 will have normal-quality Spirit Qi whilst floors 10-20 will have higher quality Spirit Qi— about a 30% improvement compared to cultivating outside normally and the rooms on floors 1 to 9. As for the rooms at the peak of the building— the 21st floor, it's about a 50% improvement. There are only three rooms available on that floor, and two of them are already occupied."

"Which floor would you like a room on?" The receptionist asked him after explaining their structure to him.

"I want the room on the 21st floor," Yuan responded without hesitation, as he only wanted the best for Yu Rou and would not accept anything less than the best.

"A-Are you sure, esteemed guest? It'll cost 1,000 gold coins to use the 21st-floor rooms for 24 hours, and you'll only be using it for a few hours..." The receptionist seemed slightly taken aback.

"1,000 gold coins!?" Yu Rou's eyes widened with shock, and she quickly tugged at Yuan's sleeves. "Brother, you don't have to spend so much money on me! We'll only be here for a few hours!"

However, Yuan shook his head with a resolute expression on his face, "Nonsense. This is the only way I can repay you for your sacrifices in the real world, and I am not going to be humble about it! I will pay for the room even if it costs 100,000 gold coins!"

Yuan quickly placed the money on the counter before Yu Rou could further persuade him and repeated, "I want a room on the 21st floor for 24 hours!"

"Right away, esteemed guest." The receptionist accepted the money with a bright smile on her face, as this would reflect positively on her position as someone who managed to rent out such an expensive room.

"Aiya... Brother... to think you'd really spend 1,000 gold coins without blinking an eye. How on earth did you obtain such wealth, anyway? Most players have at most a few dozen gold coins after grinding for days, and even the richest players out there that spend real money on the game wouldn't dare to spend so lavishly." Yu Rou sighed loudly, shocked speechless by Yuan's unhealthy spending habit.

Alas, if only she knew that he'd spent 350,000 gold coins just to meet her. One could only imagine the face she'd make then.

"If you don't mind me asking for your name, esteemed guest..."

"Yua— Yu Tian..." Yuan stuttered.

"Young Master Yu Tian, right? Please give me a moment to bring you the key."

A few moments later, the receptionist returned with a circular medallion that appeared to be made from some sort of jade or crystal and handed it to Yuan.

"The time will start from the moment you open the door with the key, and once the 24 hours is up, the room will block all Spirit Qi from entering the room." The receptionist explained to him afterward.

"I see. Thank you." Yuan said to her before walking up the stairs with the group.

Chapter 64 - Xiao Hua's Mission

Chapter 64 - Xiao Hua's Mission

After walking up 20 flights of stairs, Yuan and his small group finally reached the 21st floor. On this floor, there existed only three doors made of stone that were eventually distanced from each other and a stone tablet right beside each door. Two of the three stone tablets already had a key inserted into the hole, signaling that it was already occupied.

Therefore, Yuan and the others walked to the stone tablet that had an empty keyhole.

After inserting the key into the keyhole, the stone door began to tremble before it started opening. However, it was unlike any normal door, and it opened by levitating off the ground.

Once they walked into the empty room, the stone door closed itself, sealing them inside.

A few moments later, the empty room began filling with rich and dense spiritual energy, and a large drawing resembling a magic circle appeared on the floor that spread throughout the entire room.

"Wow, this feels entirely different from the Spirit Qi from the outside," Yuan expressed his surprise after feeling the spiritual energy in the room.

"There's a special array in the room that attracts Spirit Qi and increases its quality." Xiao Hua explained to him.

"Array? What is that?" Yuan continued to ask her.

"Arrays are also known as formations and they are techniques with an area of effect created by Array Masters, and anything inside that formation will have to obey the law set by the formation master within the array. For

example, if one were to set a movement restriction array inside this room, we would have our movements restricted in some way until we leave this room."

"I see... So that's what these weird symbols on the floor are..." Yuan said as he looked at the massive magic circle on the floor.

"Arrays circles usually reveal themselves after activation, hence why they are often used as traps by Array Masters," Xiao Hua said to him.

"Anyway, I am going to start cultivating now." Yu Rou suddenly said as she sat down in the middle of the room in the lotus position.

A few moments later, her breathing calmed down and became somewhat rhythmic.

«You have cultivated for the first time, unlocking Qi Experience»

A notification appeared before her as she absorbed her first Qi.

«Due to Qi Gathering Array, your Qi absorption rate has increased slightly»

1/5,000

3/5,000

4/5,000

6/5,000

7/5,000

9/5,000

While Yu Rou cultivated in silence, Yuan mumbled to Xiao Hua in a low voice to not distract Yu Rou.

"Xiao Hua, do you think you can let my sister learn the Divine-grade technique, too?" he asked her.

However, Xiao Hua quickly shook her head and said, "Because Xiao Hua is not from the Lower Heaven, Xiao Hua cannot help those in the Lower Heaven, or she will be punished by the Heavens."

"Huh? Then why are you helping me?" Yuan looked at her with a baffled face.

"Because Xiao Hua has chosen Brother Yu— Brother Tian to assist her with the Supreme Heaven's Legacy, and Xiao Hua can only help those who are participating in the Legacy."

"I have heard this before, but what exactly is the Supreme Heaven's Legacy?"

"The Supreme Heaven's Legacy is a mission given to Xiao Hua by the Heavens that she must fulfill, and Xiao Hua's mission is to find someone who can climb the Stairway to Heaven and reach the Supreme Heaven."

"Why are you burdened with this mission? And what happens if you fail?" Yuan raised his eyebrows in a puzzled manner, feeling more confused than in the beginning.

However, Xiao Hua did not immediately respond to him, even looking hesitant on speaking, almost like she was afraid of something.

"If you don't want to tell me now, you don't have to. Tell me whenever you feel ready, I'll always be willing to listen," Yuan said to her a moment later.

"Thank you, Brother Tian..." she nodded with a relieved look on her face.

"Then can you tell me about this Stairway to Heavens?" he continued to ask.

"Yes. The Stairway to Heaven is a path that will lead one to a higher realm if they manage to pass the challenges on that path."

"Oh, I remember you saying something about defeating the Realm Guardian before we can ascend to a higher realm." Yuan suddenly recalled his conversation with her around the time he defeated the Jade Frog.

Xiao Hua nodded and continued, "There are multiple Stairway to Heaven in this world, and there is a Realm Guardian at the end of every stairway before one can ascend to the next realm."

"Then where is this Stairway to Heaven? I would like to see it."

"Brother Tian is still too weak to challenge the Stairway to Heaven— he'll only die if he went right now," Xiao Hua spoke to him with a serious expression on her face.

"At what level should I challenge it, then?"

"Spirit Grandmaster... that's the lowest requirement for climbing the Stairway to Heaven even if you are a genius," she quickly replied.

"Spirit Grandmaster... that's quite far away..." Yuan sighed.

"With Brother Tian's talent, he'll reach Spirit Grandmaster in no time," Xiao Hua spoke in a confident voice.

About an hour later, Yu Rou opened her eyes and spoke in an excited voice, "Brother! I have entered the First Level Spirit Apprentice and became a Cultivator!"

«You have succeeded in breaking through your mortal shackles, becoming a Spirit Apprentice!»

«All stats +50»

"Congratulations, Yu Rou," Yuan said to her with a smile on his face.

"Un! I am going to cultivate some more before we start our adventure! Please be patient with me just a little longer, Brother Tian!" she said.

"Take as long as you need, I won't complain no matter how long you make me wait..." Yuan said with a bittersweet smile on his face.

If Yu Rou has the patience to take care of him nearly every day for the past five years without uttering a single complaint, he definitely won't complain

about a few mere hours.

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Chapter 65 - Spoiling Yu Rou

After spending another hour inside the cultivation room, Yu Rou entered the second level Spirit Apprentice realm.

«You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough»

«You have reached Second Level Spirit Apprentice»

«All stats +75»

Two more hours later, she entered the third level Spirit Apprentice.

«You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough»

«You have reached Third Level Spirit Apprentice»

«All stats +100»

"Brother, I have cultivated enough, let's do something else." Yu Rou said to him afterward.

"Are you sure? You can cultivate some more if you want," he said to her.

"Honestly, I want to continue cultivating because I don't want to waste the 1,000 gold coins you'd spent to rent this room, but I also don't want to waste time cultivating here..." Yu Rou sighed with a perplexed expression on her face.

"I'm telling you, it's only 1,000 gold coins. I can earn that much by killing a few monsters and selling their monster cores," he said to her.

"Really? You can earn that much money from fighting monsters?" Yu Rou looked at him with suspicious eyes. If one could earn money using that method, wouldn't everyone be rich with gold coins by now?

"Of course." Yuan nodded.

"Anyway, if you want to leave, let's go buy you some equipment. We cannot have you leaving the city barehanded," he said to her.

Yu Rou nodded and followed Yuan outside the room. But before they could leave, they had to pull a lever next to the door so that it would open.

After leaving the room, Yuan took the key from the stone tablet and walked downstairs with the others.

"There are still 20 hours left. Give it to the next person that comes here." Yuan said as he handed the dumbfounded receptionist the key.

"Esteemed guest! You can simply keep this key with you and use it the next you come to our Cultivators' Haven. Furthermore, we have many branches across the Eastern Continent, and as long as you have this key, you can rent a room in any of the other branches." The receptionist explained to him.

"Really?" Yuan raised his eyebrows, "Then I'll give it to my little sister here. She can use it in the future."

Since he can cultivate by consuming monster cores, he didn't need to use niche places like the Cultivators' Haven to improve his cultivation.

"I would also like to spend 30,000 gold coins to buy more time in case she needs it in the future," Yuan said as he handed the money to the surprised receptionist.

"R-Right away, esteemed guest!" The receptionist quickly accepted the money and ran to the back.

"Brother!!!" Yu Rou suddenly called out to him.

"What?" He turned to look at her with an innocent-looking face.

"30,000 gold coins!? Even if you have that much money, you shouldn't have spent it on me!" she quickly lectured him.

30,000 gold coins were worth about 300,000 dollars in the real world— it was a massive fortune to spend on anything, much less renting out some cultivation room.

"Trust me, Yu Rou. It's only 30,000 gold coins. Your brother has plenty left. And it's a good investment in case we cannot play together and you want to improve your cultivation in a safe environment. Although it may seem overboard, you are already behind the majority of the players in terms of cultivation, and this will help you catch up even if it's only a little."

"..." Yu Rou was speechless, mostly because what Yuan said made sense. There will definitely be days where they won't be able to play with each other, and if she wants to improve cultivation during such days, she can simply go to the Cultivators' Haven and cultivate safely and peacefully, as she didn't like fighting or shedding blood.

A few minutes later, the receptionist returned with a new key and handed it to Yuan, "Esteemed guest, there is 40 days worth of time in this key. Please keep it safe."

"Huh? 40 days?" Yuan raised his eyebrows, as the math didn't add up.

"Yes, we have decided to give you 10 days as a bonus for doing business with us." The receptionist said with a smile on her face.

«Cultivators' Haven has been added to your Associations!»

«Your relationship with Cultivators' Haven has slightly increased from doing business with them!»

"I see... Thank you..." Yuan accepted the new key before giving it to Yu Rou.

"Thank you, Brother..." She accepted the key.

"Oh, I happen to have an extra storage pouch here. You can take this and keep your items inside." Yuan said as he handed her a storage pouch. Since he also has a spatial ring, he didn't need a storage pouch.

"You also have a storage pouch? Just how on earth did you obtain such a rare treasure? Only a handful of players have a storage pouch, and they are all top players!" Yu Rou looked at him with wide eyes. Did he really just play around this entire time? There was simply no way that a casual player would have so much money at this point of the game, much less a storage pouch. Just what on earth has he been doing in this game?

"Ah, it was given to me as a gift," Yuan said.

"A gift!? Whoever gave you this must be incredibly rich and generous." Yu Rou sighed in admiration.

"Anyway, let's find a store and get you some equipment," Yuan said a moment later.

"I feel bad for making you waste so much money on me, Brother... You are spoiling me too much."

"I am only getting started," he responded with a proud expression, feeling refreshed that he can finally be of help to Yu Rou. "In fact, I am going to spoil you until I am satisfied!"

Yu Rou merely shook her head and spoke with a bittersweet smile, "Although I am grateful, don't blame me when you are out of money..."

"I can simply hunt a few monsters and sell their monster core at that time!" He said with a bright smile on his face, and they began walking around Spring City in search of an equipment store.

Chapter 66 - Spirit Weaver

After walking around the city for some time, Yuan and the others finally decided on an equipment store that was named 'Spring City's Spiritual Treasures'.

Once they entered the store, the middle-aged man behind the counter shouted: "Welcome to our equipment store! What kind of equipment are the young ones looking for?"

"Hmm... What kind of weapon do you want to use?" Yuan asked her.

"I'm not sure, but something light and small is preferred," she said.

"Something light and small, huh?" The middle-aged man began to ponder for a moment before speaking, "We have daggers, throwing knives, and fans. Which of these suit the young lady's taste more?"

"Fans? They are considered as weapons?" Yuan was surprised, as this is his first time hearing such a thing.

"Of course! Anything can be a weapon in the hands of a Cultivator! However, fans are not commonly used due to their fragile appearance and weak presence, and most people prefer something that looks strong or cool — something like a sword." The middle-aged man explained to him.

"Can I look at the fans?" Yu Rou then asked.

"Sure thing! These are the best fans we have in store at the moment!"

The middle-aged man then retrieved a long wooden box from the room behind and placed it on the counter.

Upon opening the box, three beautiful fans that seemed to be made of special materials were revealed to Yu Rou.

"Wow... It's beautiful..." Yu Rou quickly became fond of these fans.

However, her excitement disappeared as quickly after seeing the prices for these fans.

«Jade Fan»

«Grade: Spirit»

«Quality: High»

«Physical Strength Required: 100»

«Mental Strength Required: 250»

«Price: 60,000 Gold»

«Red Metal Fan»

«Quality: High»

«Physical Strength Required: 170»

«Mental Strength Required: 300»

«Price: 75,000 Gold»

«Spirit Weaver»

«Quality: Peak»

«Physical Strength Required: 50»

«Mental Strength Required: 300»

«Price: 200,000 Gold»

"Do you have something less expensive...? A common fan is fine, too..." Yu Rou said to the middle-aged man while sighing inwardly. There was simply no way that she could shamelessly ask her brother to buy something so expensive for her after he'd already wasted 30,000 gold on her.

"If you want something normal, you can find them on the shelves over there. Most of them are less than 5 gold coins." The middle-aged man spoke as he pointed at the wooden shelves by the window.

However, Yuan suddenly spoke as the middle-aged man prepared to close the wooden box, "Wait, I will buy the Spirit Weaver."

"Eh?"

The middle-aged man immediately stopped his movements to look at Yuan, as did Yu Rou, who stared at him with a gawking expression on her face.

"Don't look at me like that, Yu Rou. I know you want it since you were staring so intensively at it." Yuan said to her with a smile as he paid the shopkeeper.

"E-Even if I want it, you can't spend 200,000 gold just like that! Just how much money do you have, Brother!?" she said to him, wondering if he'd taken out a loan from somewhere shady.

"I have enough..." he said with a smile.

"Thank you for the purchase, Young Master!" The middle-aged man changed the way he addressed Yuan, even speaking in a more respectful voice.

After counting the money, the middle-aged man handed the beautiful white fan to him and said, "The reason this one is more expensive than the others is not only because of its peak-quality but because this treasure was born naturally, and naturally born treasures are naturally more expensive than man-made treasures."

After accepting the white fan, Yuan extended his arms at Yu Rou and said to her, "Money is meant to be spent or else it isn't worth anything, Yu Rou. Furthermore, this is only a game. Accept it."

"While that is true, you still shouldn't spend so lavishly. Who do you think you are? Player Yuan, the richest player in the game?" Yu Rou shook her head with a defeated smile on her face.

"..."

The smile on Yuan's face immediately stiffened after hearing her words, and he didn't dare to respond to her question, fearing that he might reveal his identity sooner than he'd planned.

A few moments later, Yu Rou looked at the Spirit Waver with sparkling eyes. "This fan is truly beautiful! While I still want to fight using servants in the future, I definitely won't stop using this fan, either!"

Hearing Yu Rou's words, the shopkeeper suddenly said, "If you want servants, you can simply go to the Beast Contract shop that's down the street. You can find all sorts of beasts there."

"Really?! Let's go take a look, brother!" Yu Rou quickly said to him.

"Okay," he nodded.

They left the equipment store shortly later and then went straight to the Beast Contract shop that was mentioned by the middle-aged man.

"Welcome to our Beast Contract store! Are you looking to form a contract with a beast today, young guests?" The receptionist behind the counter called out to them after seeing them enter the store.

"We're just looking around for now," Yu Rou said.

"Perhaps I can help you with what you're looking for. What kind of beasts are you looking to get? We have matured beasts, young beasts, and even ones that are waiting to hatch."

"You sell even unhatched beasts? How does that work? I thought you can only form a contract with beasts with a will." Yu Rou asked.

"We simply do what's called a Forced Contract, which will forcefully establish a relationship between the unhatched beast and the seller so that they will be contracted to you immediately after their birth. Most customers tend to go for unhatched beasts because they are much easier to train than the young ones while the mature ones are harder to control. Of course, unhatched beasts are also more expensive than the others."

"Do you want to buy a servant here, Yu Rou?" Yuan asked her sometime later.

She shook her head and said, "No, I don't think I want to form a contract in such an unhealthy manner. I'd rather not force a contract and find a beast that's willing to become my servant, which will make our relationship that much more trustworthy and real."

"I understand," Yuan nodded.

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Chapter 67 - Repeatable Quests

After leaving the Contract Beast store, Yuan asked Yu Rou, "What do you want to do now that you have a weapon?"

"Since this is a game, we should be completing quests and clearing dungeons for rewards, right?" she said to him.

"What have you been doing with Xiao Hua?" she then asked.

"Well... we mostly wander the wilderness and fight monsters," he responded after a quick ponder.

"That's all you've been doing? What about quests?" she looked at them with wide eyes.

"Uh... we completed only two quests so far."

"Two!? And you somehow managed to obtain so much money!? I don't believe you, brother. There must be something unique that you're doing differently from the other players for you to have so much money."

"Then do you want to hunt monsters with us? Of course, we'll only fight monsters at your level," Yuan suggested.

However, she shook her head and said, "We can fight monsters later. I want to experience more of this world first, so I am going to do a few small quests."

"You know where to find quests?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"Un. Most shops hand out quests if you asked," she nodded.

"Where did you learn that? I didn't even know about that!" he said.

"The internet is a wonderful source of information. You can learn almost everything on it. Anyway, this is how most players are earning their money — by doing quests and clearing dungeons."

"But since we have plenty of time to play together, I want to enjoy the casual things in this game with you before we start doing the serious stuff like clearing dungeons and hunting monsters."

"I am okay with that," Yuan nodded. "I will follow you around now, so lead the way."

"Okay!"

Yu Rou then led Yuan around Spring City until she found a medicine store and went inside.

"Hello, I am looking for a quest. Does this store need assistance with something?" Yu Rou asked the receptionist a moment later.

The receptionist nodded and said, "Oh, thank you for asking! I have been running low on some herbs, so if you don't mind, can you bring me 3 jins of Spirit Grass? They can be found ten miles away from the city."

«You have received a quest from 'Mr. Qiang's Medicine Shop'»

«Quest: Gathering Spirit Grass»

«Difficulty: Easy»

«Quest Description: Bring back 3 jins of Spirit Grass to Mr. Qiang's Medicine Shop»

«Reward: 30 silver»

"We'll be back with the Spirit Grass." Yu Rou said to the old man before walking out of the store with Yuan.

"That's it?" Yuan was surprised by how easy it was for them to receive quests.

"What did you expect, brother?" Yu Rou looked at him weirdly.

"Nothing... it's just that compared to the quests I have done, this is kind of... boring?"

"I don't know what kind of quest you've done but this is quite normal for quests, and it's also very popular among the players since it's relatively safe and rewarding."

'30 silvers are rewarding?' Yuan raised his eyebrows. Compared to the rewards he's been given, 30 silvers is practically nothing.

Seeing Yuan's doubtful look, Yu Rou said, "30 silvers may not seem much to someone as rich as you, but it's a considerable amount for other players. If one completes these quests ten times, they would have enough for common equipment and whatnot."

"Repeatable quests, huh..." Yuan nodded.

"Anyway, let's go harvest some Spirit Grass. I have already done some research last night about this place so I know pretty much everything that's around Spring City, including the location of Spirit Grass," Yu Rou said as she led Yuan outside the city.

"As expected of you, always prepared." Yuan smiled at her enthusiasm.

Sometime later, they left Spring City and began making their way towards the Spirit Grass.

"Brother Tian, there are some low-level Spirit Apprentice beasts ahead." Xiao Hua suddenly warned them.

Yuan then said to Yu Rou, "I will take care of them."

"Be careful, brother..." she nodded.

Yuan then retrieved the Starry Abyss and silently approached the monsters.

'Three Horned Pig at the third level Spirit Apprentice... This is a good time for me to use the Starry Abyss and practice my dagger skills...' Yuan thought to himself.

Once he was close enough, Yuan suddenly rushed forward and swung the Starry Abyss according to the techniques he'd learned from the Thousand Knife Techniques.

Whoosh!

The black dagger in Yuan's grasp flickered, and the three monsters were cleanly beheaded the following second without even having the chance to react.

'Hm? This feeling isn't that bad.' Yuan looked at the Starry Abyss with a pleasantly surprised face.

Meanwhile, Yu Rou stared at the scene with a shocked expression.

'His movements are so fast and crisp! I didn't even notice his arm had moved until he beheaded the monsters!' she cried inwardly after witnessing Yuan's prowess. If only she knew that this is his first time wielding a dagger.

"That was amazing, brother! You looked like an entirely different person just now!" She praised him afterward. "I guess you weren't lying when you said that you had hunted a lot of monsters!"

"Your cultivation must be fairly high right now. What's your cultivation, brother?" she then asked him.

"That's a secret," he said with a mysterious smile on his face.

"Eh? Why would you keep that a secret?" she raised her eyebrows.

"Because it's for a surprise I have for you later," he quickly replied.

"Hmm..." Yu Rou narrowed her eyes at him with a suspicious gaze.

Seeing this, Yuan laughed nervously before saying, "Anyway, now that the monsters are dealt with, let's continue."

"Huh? You're going to leave just like that? What about these three monsters?" Yu Rou suddenly asked him.

"What do you mean? What about these three monsters?" Yuan tilted his head in a puzzled manner.

"Don't tell me you were actually going to leave behind so much material on the ground?! That's so wasteful! If we sell these monsters' meat and bones to the store, we can earn much more money!" she explained to him.

"Oh... I never thought about that..." he mumbled in a low voice.

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Chapter 68 - Divine Sense

'Did he really earn all that money just from selling monster cores? I cannot imagine how many monster cores one would need in order to earn hundreds of thousands of gold coins...' Yu Rou shook her head helplessly as Yuan, who didn't even know about selling the monsters' materials.

"Brother, we can either chop these pigs up like a butcher would and sell their materials separately or just sell the whole corpse at once. Which method would you rather choose? We'd earn more money from selling the materials individually, but it'll also require much more work," Yu Rou said to him a moment later.

"Let me chop them up for you," Yuan said to her.

"Do you know how to...?" Yu Rou looked at him with a doubting gaze. Butchering a whole monster is not something one can do without training and experience.

"Yes, I have this cooking technique called Thousand Knife Technique, and when I look at these corpses, my mind automatically tells me how to butcher it with my dagger, almost like it's only natural," Yuan said to her.

"Really? But I am more interested in why you have a technique meant for cooking..." she said to him.

"I'm not sure since I have never done it, but I feel very confident when looking at it."

Yuan approached the three Horned Pigs with the Starry Abyss still in his grasp. He then knelt in front of the corpses and began cutting monster corpses with the dagger.

His movements were neither too slow nor too fast with each cut done in a single smooth motion, making all of his movement appear extremely natural, almost like he has years of experience already.

"Wow... And you learned that from a cooking technique?" Yu Rou mumbled in awe.

"Yes. Do you want to learn it, too? I still have the technique book with me," Yuan asked her.

"You can share techniques with others?" Yu Rou raised her eyebrows.

"We'll know once we try it. Let me finish up butchering this pig, though."

After completely butchering the first horned pig perfectly, Yuan began working on the second horned pig, and his movements appeared even cleaner than previously.

"As expected of Brother Tian, he's learning at an extremely fast pace." Xiao Hua nodded her head in approval after seeing Yuan skillfully butcher the horned pigs.

"I'm not surprised, since my brother is a genius who learned to play nearly every instrument in the world professionally when he was only five years old, after all." Yu Rou also nodded her head, agreeing with Xiao Hua.

"Brother Tian can play the instrument?" Xiao Hua looked at him with wide eyes. Is there something this guy can't do?

"Not only can he play the instrument but he can play them flawlessly! There used to be tens of millions of people who admire—"

"That's enough, Yu Rou. It's all in the past. There's no need to bring it up anymore..." Yuan suddenly interrupted her with a solemn expression on his face.

"Oh... I am sorry, brother. I got too excited and brought up something I shouldn't have again..." Yu Rou quickly realized her mistake and apologized to him.

Although Yuan used to play the instrument, because of his illness that crippled his sight, he was forced to adapt to playing the instruments while blind and until he can no longer physically move his body.

"..."

Seeing the depressing atmosphere around them, Xiao Hua decided to not ask any questions for now and silently watched Yuan butcher the last horned pig.

A few minutes later, once all three Horned Pigs were flawlessly butchered by Yuan, he tossed the materials into his spatial ring.

"I'm speechless, brother. Even though that was your first time butchering a pig—a monster, you didn't make a mess! Even your hands are clean! It's almost like you never did it!" Yu Rou expressed her admiration for him once again.

"It's mostly thanks to the knife technique that I could even cut it at all and this knife that made it much smoother," Yuan said.

"Here, why don't you take a look at the technique yourself?" Yuan retrieved the Thousand Knife Technique he'd bought from the store and handed it to Yu Rou.

"It's like a book," she said as she began flipping through the pages.

Sometime later, Yu Rou finished reading the entire technique. She looked at Yuan with a tilted head and spoke, "How did you learn the technique? I read the entire thing word by word and still don't have the skill."

"I did exactly what you just did—I read the book," Yuan said.

He then turned to look at Xiao Hua and asked her, "Are these techniques a one-time use thing? If I already learned a technique from it, others won't be able to do the same?"

However, Xiao Hua shook her head and said, "That's not possible. Techniques are not like monster cores where they disappear after one use—

as long as you can comprehend the technique, you should be able to learn it."

"Then why can't I learn it?" Yu Rou asked her.

"That's simply because you haven't comprehended the technique. Unless you are a cultivation prodigy like Brother Tian who can comprehend something at a mere glance, you'll need to read that book over and over again until you can comprehend it. Of course, it is also possible that you are not compatible with the technique. If that's the case, you won't learn the technique no matter how many times you read it. However, that usually happens only with the more profound techniques— not some ordinary cooking technique."

"Oh... Then I'll try again at another time," Yu Rou said, sounding somewhat disappointed.

Yuan and the others returned to finding the Spirit Grass shortly later.

During their journey, they encountered two more monsters, both at the second level Spirit Apprentice realm, which Yuan swiftly and casually dealt with before spending some more time butchering.

Two hours have passed since Yuan and the others began the quest, and they have just reached the area where the Spirit Grass was located.

"What does Spirit Grass look like?" Yuan asked after they reached the location.

"It's like regular grass but with a blue tip— like this one," Yu Rou spoke as she harvested a single blade of Spirit Grass before showing it to Yuan.

"We need 3 jins of these? That's going to take forever!" Yuan's eyes widened after seeing the small grass.

"Actually, these are much heavier than regular grass, so we don't need as much as you think. Here, see for yourself." Yu Rou handed him the Spirit Grass.

"Wow! You're right! I can actually feel some weight behind it!" Yuan expressed awe. How can something so tiny and light-looking have such weight to it?

"Brother Tian, the most deceiving thing in the cultivation world is one's appearance. You should never judge a book by its cover, or you'll regret it." Xiao Hua warned him.

Yuan nodded his head before he began looking around.

After spending a few minutes looking around, Yuan decided to stop using his eyes to look for the Spirit Grass and began to try something new.

'The Spirit Grass has a unique aura to it... If I can sense it with my cultivation, I should be able to find them even without needing to use my eyes...'

Yuan then began expanding his own aura until he could sense things a few meters around him.

'Wow... Even though my eyes are closed, I can somehow still see the world in my mind, and it seems even clearer than using my eyes...' Yuan was amazed by this new finding. If only he could use this same technique in the real world. That way, he would still be able to see despite being blind.

«You have learned Divine Sense»

«Divine Sense»

«Rank: Earth»

«Mastery Level: 1»

«Description: As long as one activates their Divine Sense, they will be able to see everything in a certain distance, even things that normally can't be seen with the bare eyes.»

And within just a few moments, Yuan was able to locate over a dozen Spirit Grass at once.

"..." Xiao Hua looked at the expanded aura around Yuan with wide eyes.

'Divine Sense? Brother Tian somehow learned to use Divine Sense by himself? Even though he can only expand his Divine Sense a few meters, that's an incredible achievement for someone who's only at the Spirit Warrior realm!' Xiao Hua thought to herself.

Normally, only Cultivators at the Spirit Master realm are able to learn and use Divine Sense, yet Yuan managed to learn it when he's only in the Spirit Warrior realm.

However, compared to eating monster cores and his godlike comprehension talent, it didn't shock Xiao Hua too much, who was already getting used to his incomprehensible existence.

"Here, Yu Rou. I found 12 Spirit Grass," Yuan showed Yu Rou the Spirit Grass he found using his Divine Sense.

"What! How did you find this many so quickly?! I only found 2 myself!" Yu Rou looked at the small pile of Spirit Grass on his hands with wide eyes.

"Why don't you try using your cultivation to sense the Spirit Grass instead of looking for them with your bare eyes? It's much easier and more efficient because they have a unique aura that distinguishes them from the rest," Yuan said to her.

"How do I do something like that?" she raised her eyebrows in a puzzled manner.

"Uhh... I'm not sure either..." Yuan scratched his head, as it was such a natural feeling for him.

Chapter 69 - Player Killer

"Brother Tian, Divine Sense is not something anyone can use, and they must have an appropriate cultivation before they can even learn it," Xiao Hua said to him.

"Oh... Is that so?" Yuan nodded. "Then I will continue to look for Spirit Grass with my Divine Sense."

Once Yuan left to look for more Spirit Grass, Yu Rou turned to look at Xiao Hua and said to her, "You know a lot of things despite your young age..."

"...Xiao Hua has existed for longer than you think," she responded with a calm voice.

"Eh? Then how old are you?" Yu Rou looked at her with wide eyes.

"..."

However, Xiao Hua did not respond to her, acting as though she was deaf.

"You can't even tell a fellow lady?" Yu Rou insisted.

"One's age does not matter when you are a Cultivator..." Xiao Hua said, avoiding the question.

Yu Rou shook her head inwardly and sighed after seeing Xiao Hua's strong reluctance.

"Anyway, I can't let Brother Tian do all of the work by himself. I'll also continue looking for Spirit Grass..." Yu Rou returned to searching for Spirit Grass with her bare eyes.

Half an hour later, Yuan returned to Yu Rou and Xiao Hua with an abundant amount of Spirit Grass in his spatial ring.

"I should have around 20 jins of Spirit Grass in my spatial ring right now," Yuan said to her.

"20 jins?! That's way more than what we need," Yu Rou said.

"Yes, but if the quest is repeatable, we can complete it multiple times in a single run," Yuan said.

"Oh, that's quite smart, brother. Meanwhile, I have only managed to find 2 jins worth of Spirit Grass..." Yu Rou sighed.

"Brother Tian, Xiao Hua also gathered some Spirit Grass for you," Xiao Hua said.

"Thank you, Xiao Hua. You can keep it to yourself until we need to hand it in," Yuan said to her.

"Un," she nodded.

"Now that we've completed the quest, let's return to the medicine store and hand in our Spirit Grass," Yu Rou said.

Thus, they began making their way back to Spring City.

However, on their way back, Yuan and his small group encountered another group of players that appeared to be heading in their direction.

"Brother Tian, there are four Cultivators at the fifth level Spirit Apprentice realm ahead," Xiao Hua said to them way before the two groups even met.

"They must be players that are doing the same quest," Yu Rou said.

Once the two groups met, the other group asked them, "Hello, are you guys coming from the Spirit Grass location?"

"Yes, that's right. It's just a mile that way," Yuan pointed in the direction they came from.

The four players then exchanged gazes with each other and nodded with a determined gaze in their eyes before turning to look at Yuan again.

"Since you know where to find more Spirit Grass and it's not too far away, why don't you do us a solid favor and hand over the ones you already have to us?" One of the players said to them, and the other three players drew their weapons.

"..."

Yuan was speechless. Are they being robbed? In broad daylight?

"And before you get any ideas, let me warn you that there are four of us and only three of you— and one of them is a mere child!" The player said.

"What should we do, brother?" Yu Rou asked him as she grabbed his sleeves.

"Hmm..." Yuan narrowed his eyes at the four players and asked them a moment later, "The four of you are players, right?"

"So what if we are?!"

"Hurry up and give us all of your Spirit Grass, or do we have to take it from your corpses!?"

"..."

Yuan ignored the four players and turned to ask Yu Rou, "Can you confirm for me that if players die, they will respawn later?"

Yu Rou nodded and said, "If a player dies, they won't be able to control their character for an hour, and they'll respawn in the last city they were in."

"Are you going to kill them?" she asked him afterward.

"Yes," he nodded with a cold expression on his face.

"..."

Xiao Hua looked at him with wide eyes. He's willingly going to kill four Cultivators? What happened to his righteous speech about not wanting to kill anyone just a few days ago?

Yuan retrieved the Starry Abyss and approached the four players with a cold gaze, and he spoke in a low voice, "I don't care if you want to rob us. I wouldn't have cared even if you wanted to kill me... However, threatening to kill my sister before me, you have crossed a line that you should've never crossed..."

The four players looked at Yuan's serious expression and began laughing out loud.

"Are you going to fight the four of us by yourself!? Who the hell do you think you are?!"

"Stop wasting our time and die already!" One of the players suddenly rushed forward and swung the sword in his grasp at Yuan with sluggish movements, looking like a complete beginner with the sword.

"..."

Yuan remained calm despite the sudden attack, even looking at the player with disdain in his eyes.

"You call that a sword attack?" Yuan casually shifted his body and barely dodged the sword.

The second he dodged the player's attack, Yuan jerked his hand forward, stabbing the player in the chest with the Starry Abyss.

"..."

The player stared at him with wide eyes filled with disbelief for a moment before falling onto the ground.

«You have killed your first player!»

«You have gained the title 'Player Killer'!»

"H-He killed our brother! Kill him and avenge our brother!"

The remaining three players immediately sprang into action after witnessing their brother being killed by Yuan, their faces filled with anger.

"Thousand Knife Technique!"

However, Yuan swung the Starry Abyss before any of the players could even get close to him, and before the players could even react, a black light flashes right before their necks.

Plop *Plop* *Plop*

The three players collapsed onto the floor simultaneously a moment later with deep cuts in their necks.

After killing the four players, Yuan stared at the corpses on the floor, feeling an indescribable feeling in his heart.

'I thought I wouldn't be able to kill people, but it was surprisingly easy...' Yuan looked at his palms that were slightly trembling.

However, he was not scared, nor was he traumatized by the experience.

"This is... excitement?" Yuan mumbled to himself in disbelief.

When he fought the four players, he didn't see it as fighting another human. Instead, it felt no different than fighting monsters.

"Brother! Are you okay!?" Yu Rou and Xiao Hua approached him a moment later.

"Are you hurt anywhere?" Yu Rou began patting him all over his body to check for injuries.

"Don't worry, I am not injured," he said with a reassuring smile.

And then he continued, "Do you think I'll be punished for killing other players?"

"I don't think so, since there are many Player Killers out there but none of them have been punished for it," Yu Rou said to him.

"I see..."

"That was your first time killing another player, right? How do you feel, brother?" Yu Rou asked him afterward.

"I don't know, but one thing for sure is that I don't feel bad about it, and knowing that they don't die permanently made it much easier," he said. "I won't let anyone hurt you, Yu Rou, no matter who they are."

"Thank you, brother..." Yu Rou nodded with a bashful expression on her slightly rosy face.

"What should we do with their corpses?" Yuan asked sometime later.

"They'll respawn in an hour, so let's take their stuff before that happens," Yu Rou said as she began rummaging through their pockets.

"Y-You're going to take their stuff?" Yuan looked at her with wide eyes, as he didn't expect to see such savageness from her.

"Why not? You know that saying 'An eye for an eye'? They tried to rob us, so it's only fair that we do the same to them. And it feels no different from dismantling a monster after killing it."

Sometime later, Yu Rou returned with a disappointed expression on her face.

"Besides their weapons, they only had fifteen silvers and some minor recovery pills on them..." she sighed, "I guess it's better than nothing."

Sometime later, they continued walking back to Spring City.

"Xiao Hua, can you tell us if there are people close to us? I don't want to risk running into more people like the ones just now," Yuan said to her.

"Okay," she nodded.

Two hours later, they returned to Spring City, and then Mr. Qiang's Medicine Shop.

"Welcome back, young lady! Did you find the Spirit Grass?" The receptionist immediately recognized her beautiful face.

"Yes, we even brought more than you'd requested if you don't mind." Yu Rou said to him.

"Oh, that's perfect! I'll pay you 10 silver more for every extra jin of Spirit Grass you have for me."

The receptionist then placed a scale on the counter and said, "Throw everything you have on here."

Yu Rou nodded and placed her 2 jins worth of Spirit Grass onto the scale.

Then Yuan placed his 20 jins of Spirit Grass into the scale.

"You gathered 22 jins of Spirit Grass in such a short amount of time? I'm amazed!" The receptionist exclaimed his admiration.

"Wait, we still have more," Yuan said and turned to look at Xiao Hua.

"How much did you gather?" he asked her.

"318 jins," she responded calmly.

"Huh?"

Everyone in the store suddenly turned to look at her with wide eyes filled with disbelief.

Chapter 70 - Divine Crystal Of Heavenly Fortune

"I-I'm sorry, young lady, but I don't think I heard you properly just now. How much Spirit Grass did you say you have?" The receptionist cleaned his ears with his pinky finger before asking.

"318 jins of Spirit Grass," Xiao Hua repeated in a calm voice.

"3-318 jins... that's a whole year's worth of supply! And you mean to tell me that you gathered that much in a few hours?" The receptionist stared at her with clear disbelief.

"Un." Xiao Hua retrieved her spatial ring before dumping out a small mountain of Spirit Grass onto the counter, crushing the entire scale flat.

"..."

The receptionist and everyone else in the store was beyond words, as most of them have never seen so much Spirit Grass in one place before, and even Yuan and Yu Rou were staring at her with wide eyes.

How on earth did she gather so much Spirit Grass? Unless she plucked the entire location of its Spirit Grass, there was no way she would have obtained so much!

"A-Anyway... No matter how you obtained these Spirit Grass, I will pay you for them." The receptionist spoke after snapping out of his daze.

"340 jins of Spirit Grass will be worth 3,400 silver, converted to gold coins will be 34 gold coins... Are you okay with this?" The receptionist said to them.

"Y-Yes, that's fine," Yu Rou nodded.

A few minutes later, after the receptionist accepted the Spirit Grass, he handed 34 gold coins to Yu Rou.

«You have completed the Quest: Gathering Spirit Qi»

«You have been rewarded with: 34 Gold Coins»

"Congratulations on completing your first quest, Yu Rou," Yuan said to her with a smile on his face. "And you can keep the gold for yourself."

"Thank you, brother! This is mostly due to you and Xiao Hua!" Yu Rou said.

After leaving the medicine store, Yuan asked Yu Rou, "What do you want to do now?"

"Hmm... After seeing how you had defeated those players with such ease, I have realized just how important it is to have a skill, so I want to use the money we'd just earned to buy some techniques."

Yuan nodded and said, "Then let's find a store that sells some techniques that can be used with a fan."

"I know just the place!" Yu Rou said, and she began leading Yuan and Xiao Hua through the city again.

About half an hour later, they reached this ordinary-looking building that gave the atmosphere of a library from the outside.

"Myriad of Techniques, huh?" Yuan read the sign above the door with a curious gaze.

"According to many players on the internet, one has a chance to obtain a free technique if they have perfect compatibility with it! Furthermore, this place sells the cheapest techniques in the entire city!" Yu Rou said as she has had her eyes set on this place ever since she learned of it.

"Let's head inside," Yuan said.

Once they entered the building, they were baffled by the luxurious interior of the building that looked the complete opposite of the outside appearance, feeling like they'd entered some exalted individual's expensive mansion instead.

They were then greeted by a beautiful young lady who was wearing what appeared to be disciple robes.

"Welcome to Myriad of Techniques, please place your hands on this crystal ball, as it will judge your qualifications." The young disciple said to them at the doorstep.

"Qualifications? Why must we qualify before we can buy techniques?" Yuan asked her, as he couldn't comprehend the meaning behind their actions.

"We have three floors in this building with different quality and ranks of technique on each floor. Every guest will automatically have access to the first floor, but if they wish to buy techniques on the second or third floor, they must pass a simple test," she explained to him.

"I see... Yu Rou, you can go first," Yuan said to her.

"Un."

She nodded her head before placing her hand on the crystal ball provided by the disciple.

A few seconds later, the clear crystal ball began glowing a beautiful golden light.

"..."

When the beautiful young lady saw this, her eyes widened with surprise, and she spoke when the light disappeared shortly later, "You... You are quite the lucky one, young girl."

"Huh? What do you mean?" Yu Rou asked her.

"The Divine Crystal of Heavenly Fortune just measured your fortune and fate, and you are apparently deeply connected to someone with a heavenly destiny," said the female disciple.

"I'm sorry, but I still don't understand..." Yu Rou spoke with an apologetic smile on her face.

"It's okay, because I don't understand it either, and I am only telling you what my Master told me to say." The female disciple said with a straight face.

"Your Master...?" Yu Rou looked around but there was nobody else there.

"Ah, my Master is on the third floor, and he is speaking to me using his Divine Sense. Anyway, you are qualified to buy techniques on the second floor." The disciple said to Yu Rou before turning to look at Xiao Hua and continued, "You are next."

Xiao Hua did not immediately place her hands on the crystal ball and stared at the female disciple with narrowed eyes, seemingly in a deep ponder.

"Is something the matter?" Yuan asked her.

"No, Xiao Hua is fine," she quickly responded before placing her small hands on the crystal ball.

The Divine Crystal of Heavenly Fortune glowed a similar golden color a few seconds later, perhaps even a little brighter than Yu Rou's result, but there was a hint of black within the center of the light.

"..."

The female disciple spoke after the light disappeared, "Just like the previous young lady, you are deeply involved with someone with a heavenly destiny, however, you also..."

When the female disciple noticed the subtle killing intent in Xiao Hua's eyes, she immediately stopped speaking with a mysterious smile on her face.

After a moment of silence, the female disciple turned to look at Yuan and continued as though Xiao Hua did not exist, "It is very rare for someone to have connections to someone with a heavenly destiny, much less two of them at once. Although it may not seem like it, my heart is beating in anticipation for your results, young man."

"Heavenly destiny... You have mentioned this word a few times now, but what exactly does that mean?" Yuan asked her.

"Well, to put it in simpler terms, they are people who are destined to create massive waves that will greatly affect the world one way or another. There are multiple ranks of destiny like minor destiny that will only affect the lower realms and major destiny that will affect the higher realms, and the highest level of destiny is the heavenly destiny. Only powerful individuals that will affect every realm under the heavens will bear such a destiny." The female disciple explained to him.

"Is that so?" Yuan nodded. While he understood the concept behind it, he didn't understand the real meaning behind having such a destiny.

'So both Yu Rou and Xiao Hua will be involved with someone like that, huh? I wonder who this person is...' Yuan pondered to himself as he placed his hands on the Divine Crystal of Heavenly Fortune.

The moment Yuan touched the Divine Crystal of Heavenly Fortune, the crystal ball trembled violently before exploding into many pieces.

"Ah!?" The female disciple cried out in a startled voice when the Divine Crystal of Heavenly Fortune suddenly exploded.

"A-Are you okay?! What happened just now?" Yuan asked her in a surprised voice.

"I-I am not injured, but the Divine Crystal of Heavenly Fortune..." The female disciple looked at the shattered crystal with a terrified look on her face, as she has never experienced something like this before.

"M-Master... the Divine Crystal of Heavenly Fortune... it exploded..." The female disciple lifted her head towards the ceiling and spoke to the empty air.

A moment later, the female disciple spoke again and with a dazed expression on her face, "R-Really? You want me to bring him to you?"

"I-I understand!" The female disciple nodded before looking at Yuan again.

"Umm... My Master would like to speak with you..."

Hearing her words, Yuan rubbed his eyes and sighed in a depressed voice, "I am going to have to pay for destroying the Divine Crystal of Heavenly Fortune, aren't I?"

"Eh? N-No! That's not it. It wasn't your fault that the Divine Crystal of Heavenly Fortune exploded... I think. Anyway, I don't know why, but my Master would like to speak with you." The female disciple said to him.

"Can we go with him?" Yu Rou suddenly asked.

"I'm sorry, but my Master only asked for his presence..." she responded with an apologetic smile.

However, Xiao Hua grabbed Yuan's sleeves with a stern look on her face.

Seeing this, the female disciple said with a smile on her face, "You can relax, little girl, we won't do anything to him."

But alas, Xiao Hua did not move a muscle and continued to grab onto Yuan's sleeves.

"It's okay, Xiao Hua. I want you to protect Yu Rou in my stead when I am gone." Yuan said to her. "Make sure nobody bullies her, okay?"

"Okay..." Xiao Hua eventually released his sleeves and watched Yuan disappear with the female disciple shortly later.

"Are you okay, Xiao Hua? You have been acting weirdly ever since we entered this building," Yu Rou asked her.

"Xiao Hua is fine..." she said to her, and she continued a moment later, "But that girl... she's a very powerful Cultivator that shouldn't exist in this Lower Heaven..."

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Chapter 71 - Translucent Dew Of Flawlessness

"Huh? What do you mean by that?" Yu Rou asked Xiao Hua, as she was unfamiliar with such terms.

"That girl with the disciple robes just now is a Cultivator at the Spirit King realm, and unless she also has a Legacy to fulfill, she's an existence that shouldn't be in this world—the Lower Heaven," Xiao Hua explained to her.

"Spirit King... Lower Heavens...?" Yu Rou shook her head, still confused about what Xiao Hua was trying to say.

"Anyway, let's look around the first floor before we go to the second floor," Yu Rou said.

"Un." Xiao Hua nodded and followed Yu Rou, as she didn't need to learn any new techniques for herself.

Meanwhile, Yuan and the female disciple had just reached the second floor.

"What is your name, young man? I am called Zhu Yuying," said the female disciple.

"Yu Tian," he responded.

"Oh, that's a nice name," she nodded with a smile on her face.

"Anyway, before you meet my Master, you should know a few things about him. First and foremost, my Master is a very outgoing individual, but do not

feel too comfortable around him, and most importantly, do not show any sign of disrespect, or else you will dearly regret it."

"I don't think I will have a problem with that..." Yuan said, as he wouldn't disrespect anyone without a good reason.

"Good. Then the next thing you should know about my Master is that he has very keen eyes for everything, so do not lie to him, because he will know," Zhu Yuying continued. "If you don't feel comfortable with answering his questions, you should just remain silent, as that is better than being a liar."

"Is he going to question me a lot?" Yuan asked.

"I don't know," she casually shrugged.

"Is that so..."

After navigating around the second floor for a few minutes, they reached the staircase for the third floor.

However, there were two guards standing by the stair with a semi-transparent barrier that blocked their access to the third floor.

"Master wants to speak with him," Zhu Yuying said to the guards.

"What? The Master is willing to meet with a stranger?" The guards looked at Yuan with wide eyes, wondering what was so special about him.

"Since it's the Master's request, go ahead."

One of the guards then snapped his fingers, and the barrier blocking their path began disappearing.

A moment later, they were free to enter the third floor.

"This is the third floor?" Yuan expressed surprise after seeing the third floor, which was only large enough to fit two 5 meter-long bookshelves on

each side and surprisingly empty, as there were barely books on these bookshelves— enough to be counted with one's hands.

"My Master is waiting for you at the other side of that door," Zhu Yuying pointed to the door at the end of the small room that emitted a profound feeling.

Yuan swallowed nervously before walking towards the door that gave him the chills.

He then opened the door, and to his surprise, there was only darkness behind this door.

"Uhhh... I am supposed to enter this?" Yuan turned around to look at Zhu Yuying, who nodded with a smile on her face.

"Don't worry, it's only a portal that will take you to my Master, who is in a place so far away that the only way you can meet him is through teleportation."

Yuan narrowed his eyes, feeling a bit uncomfortable about the weird atmosphere and the whole situation. What if they are trying to trick him just like what happened at the Demonic Spider's Silent Cave?

However, as Yuan was wondering whether to trust them, an ancient voice resounded in his head: "It isn't polite to make the Seniors wait so long, young man."

And right as the voice ended in his head, a powerful force appeared from beyond the door, sucking him inside the darkness.

"Ahhhhhh!"

Yuan screamed out loud as his body was tossed into the darkness, feeling like he was falling constantly through an endless hole.

The falling sensation lasted for a good minute before the darkness suddenly vanished, replaced by a bright light.

Yuan looked around, and to his surprise, he was surrounded by clouds, and when he looked down, he saw a vast world— one that stretched to the horizons.

«You have discovered ???»

"What the heck?! Where am I?! What happened to the technique store?!" Yuan exclaimed in a shocked voice as he continued falling from the sky.

"I'm going to die! I am definitely going to die if I fall from this height!" Yuan cried out loud.

"Hahaha... Calm down, young man from another world— you won't die."

A similar voice suddenly resounded beside Yuan, causing him to turn around.

"You are..."

Yuan's eyes widened with shock when he saw a healthy-looking old man with long white hair and a long beard falling beside him.

The old man suddenly waved his sleeves, and as though gravity had stopped working, their body immediately stopped falling.

"Come with me."

The old man began flying away, and Yuan could feel an invisible force pulling him along.

A few minutes later, they landed on this small floating island that had a beautiful jade table in the center and two jade chairs beside it.

Once they landed, the old man immediately walked to one of the chairs and sat down before taking out a teapot and two teacups.

"Sit down, young friend." The old man gestured to him in a friendly manner.

"..."

Although Yuan was still trying to make sense of the situation, he sat down as instructed.

"Try this."

The old man handed him one of the teacups.

"T-Thank you..."

Yuan accepted the teacup without thinking and looked at the transparent liquid in the cup. If he hadn't seen the ripple on the surface, he would've mistaken it as an empty teacup.

The old man then pulled the teacup towards his own lips before chugging the cup of liquid in an instant.

Yuan followed the old man's actions and drank the transparent liquid.

"Wow..."

Yuan could feel a refreshing feeling flow down his throat before it expanded in his stomach and then the rest of his body, feeling almost like an explosion had occurred within his body.

«You consumed a Translucent Dew of Flawlessness»

«Impurities will now be cleansed from your body»

A few seconds after consuming the translucent liquid, sticky black substances could be seen oozing from every pore on Yuan's body, filling the place with an intense smell that resembled the smell of rotten eggs and many other unpleasant smells.

"Whoa! What is happening to me?!" Yuan stood up in a panic after seeing this scene.

"Your body is currently discharging the impurities within your body. One must reach the Spirit Grandmaster realm before they can start cleaning the impurities within their body, but the Translucent Dew of Flawlessness will help you achieve that regardless of your cultivation, and it will continue to protect your body from collecting any more impurities in the future so that you don't have to waste time manually discharging the impurities within your body after every breakthrough." The old man explained to him in a calm voice.

"The Translucent Dew of Flawlessness is a rare treasure that will be very beneficial to you and your future cultivation."

"I don't really understand it, but thank you for giving me such a treasure, Senior." Yuan bowed to him with his body nearly covered in impurities.

"No need to thank me, as this is but a small token for making you come all the way to this place." The old man smiled.

A few minutes later, once Yuan discharged every drop of impurity that was contaminating his body, the old man waved his sleeves, creating a powerful wind that blew away the impurities and the awful smell.

«You have cleaned every drop of impurity within your body, obtaining a Refined Body!»

«You have gained the title 'Untainted Body'»

«Description: Having an untainted body, your cultivation speed will increase significantly as long as you keep your body clear of impurities»

"How do you feel, young man?" The old man asked him afterward.

"I don't know how I should describe this refreshing feeling... It feels almost like I have been reborn..." Yuan said while staring at his own palms, feeling incredibly light and energetic, even powerful.

"Rebirth, huh? That's a good way to describe it." The old man nodded before pointing at the seat.

Once Yuan was seated again, the old man spoke, "I know you are wondering why I brought you to this place and where we are, so let's get that out of the way first."

"First of all, this place is not a location from where you came from— the Lower Heaven— or anywhere in the world for that matter. It is its own world— another dimension so to speak, hence why I was able to bring you here without much trouble."

"Now as for why I brought you to this place, it's simply because I want to know more about you— young man who destroyed the Divine Crystal of Heavenly Fortune with his destiny."

"Huh?" Yuan looked at the old man with wide eyes. So he really was responsible for destroying that treasure!

"However, before we continue, why don't we introduce ourselves?" The old man spoke, and he continued, "Most people address me as Master Bai, but you can just call me Senior Bai."

Yuan nodded and said, "My real name is Yu Tian, but I am also known as Yuan."

"Yu Tian, huh?" Senior Bai nodded his head before continuing, "Now then, continuing with the matter— the reason why the Divine Crystal of Heavenly Fortune exploded after trying to read your fortune is simply because it could not read your destiny, hence why it exploded."

"...Huh?" Yuan looked at him with his eyebrows raised in a puzzled manner. What does he mean by that?

Chapter 72 - An Unknown Destiny

"The Divine Crystal of Heavenly Fortune is a very powerful treasure that can read one's fortune and destiny, and depending on the importance of their destiny, they are given a rating. There are countless geniuses in this world who have the ability to change or create history, but very few of them will be given a minor destiny. Then we have the major destiny, geniuses who will affect the heavens to a certain extent. Someone with a major destiny will appear every once every ten thousand years." Senior Bai explained to him the functions of the treasure he destroyed.

"As for the final rating— heavenly destiny... There have been only 13 people who were given such a destiny ever since the ancient times, and every single one of these individuals had greatly affected the world so much that they were given their own Era."

"However, not many people know this, but there is actually another rating beside the three I just explained, and there is no name for such a destiny, hence why I just call it the unknown destiny."

"The unknown destiny is the only destiny the Divine Crystal of Heavenly Fortune cannot read or sometimes mistake as a heavenly destiny, and in the cases where the Divine Crystal of Heavenly Fortune cannot read a destiny, it will explode."

After the lengthy explanation, Senior Bai gave Yuan a moment to digest the information before continuing, "Ever since the ancient times... No... ever since the first Cultivator learned to cultivate, there have only been two other individuals other than yourself that have had an unknown destiny, and I want to know what kind of person you are as the third person to have an unknown destiny, hence why I brought you here."

"I see... but what do you want to know about me? I have lived an insignificant life for the majority of my life, so I don't think you'll find anything interesting about me," Yuan said to him.

"Your life experiences don't matter to me. What I want to know is your ambitions— why you decided to become a Cultivator and what keeps you on the cultivation path," Senior Bai said to him.

"My ambitions...?" Yuan lifted his eyebrows before speaking in a calm voice, "Honestly, I don't have any ambitions, and I only want to enjoy this beautiful world with my little sister and hopefully make some friends."

"You have no ambitions? That's quite hard to believe, as every Cultivator has a dream."

Despite expressing his doubt, Senior Bai was unable to sense any lies from Yuan's clear gaze.

"Although I may not have any ambitions, I do have a dream. However, this dream is not something one can achieve just by working hard for it." Yuan said with a bitter smile on his face.

"Hoh? Do you mind clarifying?" Senior Bai asked him with his interest piqued. "In the cultivation world, there is almost no dream that cannot be attained through hard work."

"What about a person who was born without legs and dreams of walking? What about a person a blind man dreams of seeing again?" Yuan asked him. "Do you think those kinds of dreams could be achieved?"

"Hahaha..." Senior Bai suddenly laughed out loud before speaking, "And here I was wondering what you were going to say. So what if one is born without legs? They can simply grow some with the help of treasures! The same goes for blind people! I know over a dozen medicines and treasures that can cure blindness!"

Yuan was speechless. They can do that in the cultivation world? However, even if that was the case, this was only a game, and once he logs off, this

so-called cultivation world will cease to exist.

"Anyway, what about becoming a Cultivator? What drove you to walk the cultivation path?" Senior Bai then asked him.

"Well, it kind of happened by chance," Yuan spoke before briefly recalling how he became a Cultivator.

"Chance? Nonsense! You are someone with an unknown destiny! Everything that happened to you or will happen to you in the future—everyone that you have met or will meet in the future, it was predetermined by fate before you were even born!" Senior Bai said before continuing, "Then why do you continue to cultivate? If you didn't choose this path, why don't you quit?"

"Because I have learned from a friend that strength means everything in this world, and without strength, I could lose everything that's important to me, hence why I continue to cultivate and continue to grow stronger, as I wish to explore this world with those who are dear to me without losing them."

"Cultivating to protect those important to you, huh? Despite hearing similar words from Cultivators countless times throughout my life, I can only respect one's desire to protect their loved ones. And your friend is right—the cultivation world is an unforgiving world that preys on the weak and rewards the strong. If you wish to explore this world, you must have enough power." Senior Bai spoke as he profoundly caressed his long white beard.

After a moment of silence, Senior Bai said, "I have a firm understanding of your character now, but people can always change, and I can only hope that you do not change too much."

"By the way, if you don't mind me asking, do you have a unique Physique? I can feel a profound feeling from your body, but I have never felt such a feeling before." Senior Bai suddenly asked.

"My Physique? I have something called the Heaven Refining Physique," he casually responded.

"Hea— Heaven Refining Physique?!?!?!?"

Senior Bai suddenly cried out loud as he stood up with a shocked expression on his face.

"Eh?" Yuan looked at Senior Bai with wide eyes, as he didn't expect such an intense reaction.

After a long moment of silence, Senior Bai cleared his throat before sitting back down.

"I see... So you are the person she met..."

"What do you mean, Senior Bai?" Yuan asked with his head tilted in a puzzled manner.

"N-Nothing, I was just talking to myself," Senior Bai quickly said with an awkward smile on his face.

"Anyway, I don't dare to keep you in this place any longer, little friend. If fate allows it, we shall meet each other again." Almost as though he was in a hurry, Senior Bai waved his sleeves, enveloping Yuan with his spiritual energy before sending Yuan flying towards the Heavens.

A few moments later, Yuan was surrounded by darkness again, but he was falling in the opposite direction this time around.

After sending Yuan back to the portal, Senior Bai stared at the sky with a dazed look on his face.

"So his name was Yu Tian, huh... To think I'd meet the genius with the Godly Physique that woman met in this place... As expected of someone with an unknown destiny."

"I would've given him a few techniques and some treasures to help out his journey, but alas..."

After standing in the same spot for an unknown amount of time, Senior Bai sighed in an annoyed tone, "I should probably let her know about our

meeting or she'll think I am trying to steal him from her or something..."

"Welcome back, Yu Tian," Zhu Yuying greeted him after he returned to the skill store. "How was your meeting with my Master?"

"I don't know how I should describe it," he said with a weird smile on his face. "Everything just happened so fast..."

"Then what did you two talk about?" she then asked.

"He asked me about my dreams and why I decided to be a Cultivator..."

"That's it?" Zhu Yuying looked at him with raised eyebrows.

"Yes," he said.

"..."

Zhu Yuying turned silent. Why would her Master call him for something casual like that? She couldn't comprehend it.

"Anyway, since you have already spoken with my Master, I'll leave you alone to look for skills now. Ah, you are allowed to buy a technique from any floor," she said to him a moment later.

"I understand. Since I am already here and there doesn't seem to be much technique up here, I'll look around this floor first before I reunite with the others."

Zhu Yuying nodded and left him alone on the third floor shortly later.

Yuan began looking around the third floor, but with only 2 bookshelves and a dozen techniques, it didn't take long for Yuan to see everything on the third floor.

And out of the dozen techniques on the third floor, there was only one technique that he could learn, as it was related to the sword.

"Demon Sealing Strike... What a powerful-sounding technique," Yuan mumbled the name of the technique with a feeling of awe.

He then opened the technique and began looking through it.

"..."

A few minutes after Yuan began reading the technique, he unknowingly entered a trance, which allowed him to indulge in the technique as though he was in his own world.

After an unknown amount of time had passed, a notification appeared before him.

«You have learned Demon Sealing Strike»

—

«Demon Sealing Strike»

«Rank: Heaven»

«Mastery Level: 1»

«Description: Consumes 1,000,000 Qi. Must wield a sword to activate. An ancient sword technique used to seal demons»

"Oh no... I learned the technique without paying for it again..." Yuan facepalmed himself afterward.

"And it's even a Heaven-rank technique... I hope I can afford it with my remaining gold, or I am going to have to borrow the difference from Xiao Hua..." he sighed.

Meanwhile, above the sky, another announcement appeared.

«Player Yuan has become the world's first player to have learned a Heaven-rank Skill! Congratulations!»

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Chapter 73 - Wind Blade

After he'd accidentally learned the Heaven-grade technique from the third floor, Yuan walked downstairs with a guilty expression on his face.

"What's the matter? You don't look so good."

The guards noticed his expression and decided to speak to him, wondering if something unpleasant had happened during his meeting with their Master.

"Uhh... I was just wondering how much this technique would cost if I were to buy it..." Yuan showed them the Demon Sealing Technique.

"The Demon Sealing Technique, huh? That's one of the rarest and more powerful techniques one can find in this store, and it's even a Heaven-grade technique, so it'll be quite costly."

Yuan immediately began sweating profusely after hearing the guards' words.

"If I recall correctly, this technique should be worth around 300,000,000 gold coins..."

"300,000,000 gold coins?!?!?!?!?!?" Yuan cried out loud, nearly collapsing from fright.

If the Demon Sealing Technique is really worth three hundred million gold coins, he wouldn't be able to buy this technique even if he'd borrowed all of Xiao Hua's money, and it would require him to sell about 10 Heaven-grade treasures to have enough money for the purchase.

'300 million gold coins... it's impossible... I cannot pay for this...' Yuan thought to himself.

While it pains him to even think about it, he'll have to skip this purchase even if it is considered theft that he learned the technique without paying for it.

'I'm sorry, Yu Rou... Even though it was by accident and it's only a game, your brother has committed a crime and is now a criminal...' he sighed inwardly.

"A-Are you sure you're okay...?" The guards asked him again, as they were confident that something was bothering him.

"No, I'm fine, really..." Yuan sighed as he turned around and began walking back upstairs.

"Where are you going, fellow Daoist?" The guard asked.

"To return this technique—I cannot afford it," he responded in a pitiful voice.

The guards exchanged looks with each other before laughing out loud, "Hahaha! Is that what you were worried about? Then you don't have to worry, since you don't have to pay for that technique."

"What?" Yuan immediately stopped walking to look at the guards with his eyes wide with disbelief.

"W-What do you mean I don't have to pay for it?" he asked them.

"I guess our senior sister forgot to tell you about this, but those who qualified to step onto the third floor are allowed to take one cultivation technique for free."

"...Are you serious?" Yuan looked at them with a doubtful gaze.

Who in their right mind would give away something worth three hundred million gold coins for free?

"Why would we lie to you? If you don't believe us, you can ask our senior sister or whoever is at the reception," said one of the guards. "Though,

they'll just tell you the same thing."

"Thank god!" Yuan suddenly released a deep sigh of relief, feeling like he'd narrowly escaped punishment after doing something bad.

"Even though it's for free, you need to make sure to check it out at the reception." The guards then warned him.

"I will! Thank you!"

Yuan left the place shortly later to look for Yu Rou and Xiao Hua.

"How large is this place...?" Yuan was at loss for words after realizing just how much larger the first and second floor was compared to the third floor.

And after walking around for a solid half an hour, Yuan was finally able to reunite with Yu Rou and Xiao Hua on the second floor.

"Brother! You're back!" Yu Rou said to him.

"Sorry for leaving you two like that," he said.

"Brother Tian, you... are you okay?" Xiao Hua was looking at him with her eyes as wide as saucers.

Yuan had only been gone for an hour at most, yet there was something vastly different about him!

"Hm? Yes, I am. Why are you asking?"

"There's something different about you..." she said.

"Oh, that's because I just removed all of the impurities in my body!" he said with an innocent smile on his face.

"You what?!" Xiao Hua exclaimed.

Cultivators can only start discharging the impurities within their body after entering the Spirit Grandmaster realm, and it usually requires years of effort

before they can remove all of the purities within their body! However, Yuan had only been gone for an hour and he somehow managed to remove all of the impurities within his body?!

There is only one treasure in this world that she knows of that could possibly achieve such a miracle— the Translucent Dew of Flawlessness!

However, such a treasure should not exist in the Lower Heavens! Hell, the Translucent Dew of Flawlessness is considered a peerless treasure even in the higher realms, as it not only removes all impurities within one's body but it will also prevent their body from building up more impurities in the future, allowing one to save a magnitude of time in their life since they no longer need to manually remove their impurities anymore, which takes time and effort that could be used towards cultivating instead!

"J-Just who did Brother Yuan meet...?" Xiao Hua asked him.

"Some Senior surnamed Bai," he said.

"Was he the one who gave you the Translucent Dew of Flawlessness?"

"Yes— he said it was a small token for taking up my time." Yuan nodded.

"..."

Xiao Hua was speechless. Just who in the world would be rich enough to give away such a valuable treasure for such a reason?

"Anyway, how has your search been going? Did you find any techniques that suit your taste?" Yuan asked Yu Rou sometime later.

"Well... Although there are not many skills that can be used with a fan, I have managed to find a skill that could be useful."

Yu Rou showed him the scroll she had in her hand.

"Wind Blades? A Mortal-rank technique that summons wind blades that cut foes from a distance..." Yuan looked at the title and description, not daring to read the content inside, fearing that he might accidentally learn it.

"This way, once I get my own servant, I'll be able to support it from a distance without being in the danger zone," Yu Rou said to him.

"I see... this technique is really fitting for you," Yuan said as he handed the technique back to her.

"What about you, brother? Did you find a technique yet?" Yu Rou then asked him.

"Yeah, I did. It's a sword technique," he said.

"What about you, Xiao Hua? You have been following me the entire time so you didn't get any chance to look around." Yu Rou turned to look at her.

"Xiao Hua doesn't need any new techniques," she shook her head.

"I see... Then let's pay for our techniques and leave this place."

"Are you sure you only want one technique? I think it'll be better if you have a few more..." Yuan said to Yu Rou.

"Are you forgetting something, brother?" Yu Rou said to him with a slight frown on her face.

"What am I forgetting?" He raised an eyebrow.

Yu Rou continued, "You may be able to learn techniques very quickly, but I don't have your talent, so it'll take me days, even weeks to even learn a single technique. What am I going to do with a bunch of techniques that I don't have the time to learn?"

"And you have already spent enough money on me. I can't let you spoil me too much, or I'll really start feeling guilty about it."

"I understand..." Yuan said.

Sometime later, they approached the cashier to pay for their techniques.

"Thank you for visiting our Myriad of Techniques! How may I help you today?" A young man greeted them from behind the counter.

"Yes, I would like to purchase these techniques..."

Yuan placed his Demon Sealing Technique and Yu Rou's Wind Blade onto the table.

"Yes, right away."

The young man picked up Yu Rou's technique first and said, "This will cost 200,000 gold coins."

"200,000 gold coins?! Why is it so expensive? It's only a Mortal-rank technique!" Yu Rou exclaimed.

Even Yuan was shocked by this unexpected price. Why is this technique so expensive compared to the techniques he'd brought?

"I don't know what to tell you, young lady. Martial Techniques such as this Wind Blade are very rare and powerful and usually worth this much, and it's a technique from the second floor. In fact, our Myriad of Techniques is very affordable and cheap when compared to most stores out there with our pricing. If you went to another store, they would probably charge around 300,000 gold coins for this technique. Though, if you want something cheaper, there are many techniques that cost less than 1,000 gold coins on the first floor with some costing even less than 100 gold coins."

"No way..." Yu Rou sighed before turning to look at Yuan. "It's okay, brother. I'll just look for something cheaper on the first floor..."

However, Yuan said, "It's okay, Yu Rou. If you want this technique, I'll buy it for you. And before you say anything to me, I already know what you're going to say, but I won't change my mind, so just keep quiet and nod your head."

"..."

After hearing his words, Yu Rou, who was about to persuade him, slowly nodded her head with a dazed look on her face.

After listening to the sibling's conversation, the young man behind the counter went to pick up the technique Yuan had picked. However, when he saw the name of this technique, his eyes widened with shock, and he turned to look at Yuan with deep respect in his eyes.

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Chapter 74 - Feeling Pain

'T-The Demon Sealing Technique! This is a technique from the third floor! And it's even the most powerful one!' The young man looked at Yuan with a feeling of deep admiration in his gaze, as only the top geniuses with at least a major destiny are qualified to step onto the third floor.

However, while the Demon Sealing Technique is an extremely powerful technique that can seal even the strongest of demons with a single move, it is also extremely hard to learn, and it will take even top geniuses many years to even grasp the surface of this technique, hence why most people avoid it.

"T-This technique will be free of charge, esteemed guest..." The young man said to Yuan with a smile on his face.

"What?! Free of charge?!" Yu Rou exclaimed with disbelief on her face. How come she has to pay 200,000 gold coins for her technique whilst Yuan won't be charged even a single coin? That's outrageous!

"Yes, one can receive a technique of their choice for free if they qualified to enter the third floor," Yuan explained to her why he didn't need to pay.

"Unfair..." Yu Rou sighed.

Sometime later, Yuan paid the young man 200,000 gold coins for Wind Blade, leaving only a little over 200,000 gold coins for himself.

'If I keep spending money at this rate, my wallet won't last, and I'll run out of money before Yu Rou returns to school!' Yuan cried inwardly.

However, no matter how much it might pain his heart or wallet, he won't be humble when it comes to helping Yu Rou.

"Thank you for your purchase, esteemed guests!"

The young man handed the techniques back to Yuan who then handed the Wind Blade to Yu Rou.

"Thank you, brother!" Yu Rou accepted the Wind Blade with an ecstatic expression on her face.

Sometime later, they left the Myriad of Techniques.

"Although I won't be here for long, I hope to see you again in the future, Daoist Yu Tian," Zhu Yuying said to him at the entrance.

"Yes, thank you for everything, too." Yuan nodded at her.

After leaving the Myriad of Techniques, Yuan asked Yu Rou, "What should we do now?"

"It's getting late, brother. And it's almost time for dinner, so we'll stop here for today."

"Okay, I will see you on the other side," Yuan said.

Yu Rou logged off a few seconds later.

"We'll be back tomorrow, Xiao Hua."

Xiao Hua nodded and disappeared into his necklace.

Yuan also logged off shortly later.

"..."

"..."

"..."

"W-What the heck?"

Yuan immediately frowned after logging off, as a strong smell that resembled rotten eggs suddenly assaulted his nose.

"What's this smell?! It smells like shit!" Yuan felt like puking, but then he realized something.

'Wait a second... this smell... I have smelled this awful smell before...' Yuan suddenly recalled the impurities his body had discharged.

However, that only made him more confused. Why would he be smelling something that he'd experienced in the game?

A moment later, the door opened, and Yu Rou walked into his room

"Brother, here I am— Ahhhh! Brother?! Are you okay?!" Yu Rou suddenly shrieked in a terrified voice shortly after entering his room.

"W-What happened, Yu Rou?!" Yuan was startled by her shouting.

"Why does this room smell so awful, and what are those black gunk sticking to your body?!"

Yu Rou exclaimed.

"B-Black gunks...?" Yuan immediately turned speechless after hearing her words.

Although he couldn't see his own body, in Yu Rou's eyes, his body was pretty much submerged in this black gunk, looking like someone had poured a bucket of waste on him.

"P-Please wait for a minute, brother! I will be right back!" Yu Rou immediately ran back outside to look for the servants.

Meanwhile, Yuan was pondering with a serious frown on his face.

'Black gunk... Impurities? No, that shouldn't be possible. Why would my real body discharge impurities when it happened in the game? But this

awful smell is exactly like the impurities in the game,' Yuan pondered and pondered, but he was unable to find an explanation for this phenomenon.

"What if... what if what happens in the game also affects the real world...?" Yuan mumbled in a low voice before turning silent again.

A moment later, he laughed, "Hahaha! What nonsense am I thinking? There's no way that's possible! If that was the case, wouldn't I also be able to cultivate in the real world?"

After laughing for a few seconds, Yuan suddenly stopped laughing and mumbled to him, "Well... it won't hurt to try..."

Yuan took a few deep breaths as he would before cultivation, and he tried to recall the technique Heaven's Secret Art.

A moment later, almost as though it was embedded inside his memories, the scripture appeared inside his head. However, just because he can remember the contents of the technique does not actually mean he'll be able to use it.

A few more moments later, Yuan took another deep breath before he started reciting the cultivation technique 'Consuming Heaven Technique' as though he was cultivating in the game.

One second... two seconds... three seconds...

"Ouch!"

Yuan suddenly cried out loud after feeling sharp pain appear all over his body, feeling as though he was being stabbed by needles everywhere, which quickly forced him to stop cultivating.

"W-What was that...?"

Yuan mumbled in a dazed voice, as he wasn't expecting anything to happen. However, to his surprise, his body actually had a reaction when he tried to cultivate! Even though it was unpleasant and very painful, it is still a reaction nonetheless!

And wanting to confirm that it was not just his imaginations, Yuan tried to cultivate again.

A few seconds later, the same pain occurred within his body.

"Ah! It hurt! It really hurts! Hahahaha! It actually hurts! I can actually feel something!" Yuan laughed loudly, as it has been a long time since he had felt any profound sensation from his body ever since it became numb and crippled.

Sometime later, Yu Rou returned to his room with a wheelchair and some servants.

Cough *Cough*

The servants were caught off guard by the intense smell and began coughing, feeling like they were being choked by the stench.

"Brother, let's get you out of that bed and clean those black gunk off your body. I have also called for a doctor who will be here shortly to look at your body." Yu Rou said to him as she pulled his body from the sticky impurities with effort and while ignoring the smell that was assaulting her nose.

Once Yuan was seated in the wheelchair, Yu Rou said to the servants, "I want this place cleaned up by tomorrow morning. However, keep some of that black gunk for the doctor to examine later."

"Yes, Young Lady."

The servants bowed to her with respect, not daring to utter a single complaint in her presence.

After Yu Rou left the room with Yuan, the servants immediately began to curse under their breaths.

"What the heck! Why do we have to clean after that cripple?!"

"What even are these black gunks? It's all sticky and nasty, not to mention its horrendous smell!"

"This is probably caused by the young master's condition. I have never seen anything like this before, but I won't be surprised he dies within the next few days..."

"Hmph! The faster he passes the better!"

"I feel bad for the young lady, who wasted so many hours of her life tending to him only for him to die like that..."

While the servants started cleaning the stinky room and the dirty bed, Yu Rou entered the bathroom with Yuan.

After taking off Yuan's clothes, Yu Rou used the showerhead to rinse the impurities off his body.

Once that was done, she began scrubbing his body that was still sitting on the wheelchair with some fragrant body wash. However, because the stench from the impurities was quite strong, Yu Rou had to wash and rinse his body three times before the rotten smell could fully disappear.

"I'm sorry, Yu Rou..." Yuan sighed.

"What are you saying now? I have been washing your body like this once a week for years now— this is not much different except for the smell." Yu Rou said to him.

And she continued, "I can only hope that it's nothing serious and the doctor can explain what had caused that black gunk to appear... It's sticky and oily like wet slime, but I have never seen anything like this before..."

"Me too..." Yuan said.

While he has an idea of what the black gunks are and why it appeared, he didn't dare to say it to her without confirmation, as he'd only sound crazy for saying such a thing.

A few minutes later, after rinsing Yuan's body for the fourth time, Yu Rou said, "Give me a moment to rinse myself off."

Sometime later, once Yu Rou cleaned the impurities that were sticking to her body, she pulled Yuan's light body off the wheelchair and carried him into the massive bathtub that was right beside them before sitting in the bathtub with him.

"How do you feel right now, brother? Does it hurt anywhere? While there are no injuries on your body, I am still worried about your condition." Yu Rou asked him while hugging his back from behind.

"No, I am perfectly fine," he quickly responded.

"Haaa... When I first saw you submerged in that black gunk, I was nearly scared to death, thinking that something terrible might have happened to you," she sighed in relief afterward.

However, she still wasn't free of worries, as she still needed to know why his body discharged that black gunk.

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Chapter 75 - Doctor Wang

After sitting in the large bathtub for a few minutes, Yu Rou suddenly noticed something different about Yuan's body, and she decided to ask, "Is it just me or... did you get fatter, brother?"

"What? Have you been feeding me more soup than usual?" Yuan responded in a puzzled voice.

"No, I measure everything I cook, and I don't recall increasing the size of your meals. However, your body is clearly fatter than before, and it's not as boney!" Yu Rou said as she looked at his bare body with a wondering look.

"Are you sure you aren't imagining things? I cannot imagine why I would suddenly grow fatter... It's not as if I had been eating more—" Yuan suddenly stopped talking midway through his sentence, as he realized something.

Although he hasn't been fed more by Yu Rou, his meals have indeed increased recently— and by a fair amount!

'Impossible... Could it be caused by my food consumption in the game...?' Yuan thought to himself, and his suspicions grew stronger.

"Well, as long as you don't grow to the point where I can no longer carry you, it should be fine, but I'll still ask the doctor about it later," Yu Rou said.

Ten minutes later, a servant knocked on the bathroom door and said from the outside, "Young Lady, Doctor Wang is here."

"Okay, let's get out now, brother." Yu Rou tightly embraced his body from behind before standing up, pulling him with her.

A few moments later, she placed him on a specially made table that was located right beside the bathtub before pressing a few buttons on the table.

Soon, warm wind began blowing from the sides of the table, quickly drying Yuan's body. In the meantime, Yu Rou dried her own body with a towel and wore a clean set of pajamas.

Once she was fully clothed, she helped Yuan with his clothes next.

After placing Yuan back on the wheelchair, Yu Rou led him outside and into another room, where an old man with greyish hair and a long beard was waiting.

"Thank you for coming here despite it being so late, Doctor Wang." Yu Rou bowed to him.

"Don't even mention it. Even if it was past midnight and I am already asleep, I would immediately come here if summoned." Doctor Wang laughed as he stood up and walked to them.

"So? What happened? You sounded pretty frantic on the phone, so I thought something must've happened to the Young Master. But he seems perfectly fine." Doctor Wang said after looking at Yuan's condition with his bare eyes. "In fact, he looks even healthier than my last visit!"

"Well, you see..." Yu Rou proceeded to explain the situation, telling Doctor Wang about the black gunks that smelled like rotten eggs and Yuan getting fatter somehow when he has only been getting lighter throughout the years.

"Black gunks that smell like rotten eggs? Interesting..." Doctor Wang closed his eyes to ponder.

After a moment of silence, he spoke, "I have only heard of such situations in ancient medicine books but have never seen it personally. Do you have a sample of the black gunks that I can look at?"

"Yes! I will be right back!" Yu Rou said as she rushed back to Yuan's room for the sample.

Once Yu Rou left the room, Doctor Wang looked at Yuan with a pitiful gaze. Out of the tens of thousands of patients he'd treated before, Yuan's condition was one-of-a-kind. While he has seen patients with similar conditions, they were mostly caused by accidents or due to natural-born illnesses. Yuan, however, is neither sick nor injured— at least not a single doctor from around the world was able to find anything wrong with his body after many years of effort. Even Doctor Wang himself, who is recognized as one of the best doctors in the world, cannot find the source of Yuan's problems and was baffled by this phenomenon.

"Young Master, have you felt any pain or uncomfortable feeling within your body lately?" Doctor Wang asked Yuan sometime later.

"No," Yuan said, not telling Doctor Wang about the pain he'd felt when he tried to cultivate.

"What about other feelings besides pain or discomfort?"

"Well, this might sound weird but I have been feeling more energetic as of lately. If I could, I would be jumping around right now," Yuan said with a bittersweet smile.

"Full of energy...?" Doctor Wang looked at Yuan with wide eyes. This is his first time hearing such words coming from Yuan's mouth.

"What about your diet? Have your meals changed lately?" Doctor Wang then asked.

"No, I am still eating nothing but soup," Yuan said in a sighing voice.

"What about the amount? Did the Young Lady increase your portions?"

"No, she told me that herself not long ago."

"I am going to feel your pulse now." Doctor Wang then turned his hand and began examining his pulses.

A few moments later, Doctor Wang retrieved a stethoscope from his bag and began listening to Yuan's heartbeats.

"Hmm... how strange..." Doctor Wang suddenly mumbled in a puzzled voice.

"Is there something wrong?" Yuan asked him with a worried frown.

"Hm? Oh, no! In fact, it's the opposite of that!" Doctor Wang responded in a surprised voice, and he continued, "My eyes were not wrong— Your condition has indeed improved since our last checkup!"

"Really?" Yuan exclaimed in an excited voice. Even though his improved condition doesn't have any meaning overall and he's still crippled, it still made him happy to know that he was getting healthier, and it will also make Yu Rou happy once she hears about it.

"I wouldn't lie to my patients even if it's the last thing I do," Doctor Wang chuckled.

A few minutes later, Yu Rou returned to the room with a small plastic container that contained a little of the impurities that were discharged by Yuan.

"Hoh? This is the blank gunk that came from the Young Master's body? Fascinating..." Doctor Wang looked at the impurities with great interest, and he continued, "It resembles dirty engine oil at glance, but I have never seen anything like this before."

"Can I open it?" He looked at Yu Rou, who immediately looked hesitant.

Yu Rou then walked to the door with Yuan before opening the door a little.

"Okay, you can open it now!" Yu Rou said to him afterward.

"..."

Doctor Wang stared at her with wide eyes. Surely, the smell isn't as bad as they make it out to be, right?

After swallowing his nervousness, Doctor Wang opened the contain slightly and took a quick sniff of the black gunk inside.

Urg!

Doctor Wang gagged after smelling the stench and immediately sealed the container again.

"What in lord's name was that foul smell?! I had many unpleasant experiences with foul smells as a doctor but this experience was almost unbearable!" Doctor Wang exclaimed with trembling hands before placing it on the floor, as he didn't even dare to touch the container anymore.

After a moment of silence, Doctor Wang continued, "I will have no idea what that black gunk is without examining it more closely with proper equipment, so I'll bring it back to my lab first thing tomorrow to examine it."

"Thank you, Doctor Wang." Yu Rou said to him from the door, still not daring to approach him.

"Anyway, I have examined the Young Master's body and wasn't able to find anything wrong or different about him except the fact that his body is slightly healthier than before." Doctor Wang gave Yu Rou a brief explanation of the results.

"Nothing wrong with him? His health even improved? Are you sure about that, Doctor Wang?" Yu Rou looked at him with a pleasantly surprised look.

"Yes, so you shouldn't worry about this incident too much. However, without identifying that black gunk, I do not dare to give you a clearer answer."

"That's okay! I am already more than satisfied with the results!" Yu Rou said with a bright smile on her face.

"Did you hear that, brother? You're getting healthier!"

"Yes... I heard..." Yuan said with a slight smile on his face.

"Anyway, since there's nothing else we can do before I examine the black gunk, I will take my leave now. Though you should continue keeping an

eye on the Young Master just in case anything else happens, and if that happens, make sure to call me and I will drop everything and run here."

"I will! Thank you again, Doctor Wang!" Yu Rou bowed to him as he left.

"Hahaha... I am envious of you, Young Master. If only I had such a caring sister to take care of me every day!" Doctor Wang laughed loudly as he disappeared from their sight.

Once Doctor Wang left, Yu Rou said to Yuan, "Brother, let's sleep together tonight. The maids are still cleaning your room, and like Doctor Wang just said— I need to keep an eye on you."

"Okay, I'll be in your care tonight," Yuan said.

A few minutes later, once Yu Rou returned to her own room with Yuan, she suddenly said, "Oh, right. You still haven't eaten because of this incident. I will be right back, brother."

After carrying Yuan onto her bed, Yu Rou disappeared into the kitchen to prepare dinner for him.

'Now that I am alone, let's try cultivating again. Even though it hurts like hell, the pain gradually lessens the more I try to cultivate.' Yuan said inwardly as he prepared himself mentally for the pain.

Sometime later, Yuan took a deep breath and began reciting the cultivation technique in his head.

Chapter 76 - Feeling Nothing But Pain

"Ouch!"

"..."

"Ah!"

"..."

"Shit!"

"..."

"Ack!"

Yuan spent nearly half an hour trying to cultivate while enduring the intense pain that came from it but to no avail, feeling nothing but pain and with no progress.

'Why? Why can't I cultivate when there's clearly a reaction? Every time I feel like I am close to a breakthrough, the pain immediately interrupts my breakthrough!' Yuan sighed inwardly.

'I guess I'll have to ask Xiao Hua and see if she knows something about this...'

Once Yu Rou returned to the room with dinner a few minutes later, Yuan decided to stop cultivating for the time being to eat dinner.

Sometime later, Yu Rou said to him, "Brother, you can go ahead and sleep first, I am going to surf the internet to see if there is anything we can do together tomorrow."

"Okay. Goodnight, Yu Rou." Yuan said to her.

"Goodnight, brother." After tucking Yuan into bed, Yu Rou went to her computer and began surfing the internet, and as usual, she went to look at the forums to see if there was anything new or important she should know about.

'Player Yuan made the headlines again? What did he do this time?' Yu Rou saw the posts that were marked 'hot' and quickly clicked on the link.

[Player Yuan has become the first player to learn a Heaven-rank technique!]

[Player Yuan shocks the world again with his insane progression speed!]

[Just how is Player Yuan these high-ranking techniques!? Click here to find out!]

'So Player Yuan now has a Divine-rank technique and a Heaven-rank technique, whilst the rest of us are still running around with Mortal-rank techniques...' Yu Rou shook her head.

This Player Yuan is simply too amazing and unfathomable. How is he able to achieve such results? What is he doing differently from others? Is he really even a real player? What if Player Yuan is actually an admin screwing with everybody? That seemed more plausible than Player Yuan being a cheater.

After reading all of the new forum threads about Player Yuan, Yu Rou for some reason decided to turn to look at her brother, who was already sound asleep on her bed.

"..."

After pondering for a good moment, she returned to the internet and searched for the Wealth Leaderboards.

"What! There are already so many people on the Wealth Leaderboards?!" Yu Rou exclaimed in a low but surprised voice.

It has only been a few days since the Wealth Leaderboards was unlocked by Player Yuan and there were already a thousand players from all around the world that has managed to amass over one million gold.

Obviously, these thousand people were not your regular players but some of the wealthiest players in the world who took advantage of their wealth to buy gold coins from other players through Real World Trading just so they can get onto the Wealth Leaderboards.

'Let's see if I can find my brother's name here...' Yu Rou began scrolling through the thousand names.

After all, if Yuan could easily take out 431,000 gold coins and spend it on her without batting an eyelid, he should be on the Wealth Leaderboards.

However, Yu Rou was unable to find the name 'Yu Tian' on the Wealth Leaderboards even after scrolling all the way to the very bottom of the list, which was not too surprising, as he'd spent nearly half a million already, and that could have kicked him off the Wealth Leaderboards.

'Now that I think about it, what is Brother Tian's name in Cultivation Online? I never got to ask him,' she thought to herself after this realization.

'Whatever, I'll just ask him tomorrow...' Yu Rou shrugged before returning to the forums, where she navigated to the 'Events' section.

Once she was in the 'Events' section, where players from all over the cultivation world share their experience with past and ongoing events to others for contribution points, which they can redeem for gold coins in-game.

'Let's see if there are any ongoing events near Spring City that we can attend together...' Yu Rou proceeded to type 'Spring City' in the search bar.

Literally, a second later, over 10 pages of results that mentioned Spring City was in front of her.

'Hmm... Most of these have already ended... Oh? What's this?'

[There will be a major event tomorrow at Spring City where the lord of the city— the Xuan Family— will be hosting a Disciple Recruitment Exam for the Dragon Essence Temple, a very prominent sect in the cultivation world! Only those above the 3rd level Spirit Apprentice realm can join!]

"Dragon Essence Temple? Recruiting disciples?" Yu Rou raised her eyebrows.

She then opened a new tab on her web browser and looked up the term 'Sect'.

"Let's see... Sects are an organization dedicated to the practice of cultivation and martial arts. Disciples from a Sect can receive training from the Sect Elders and may even obtain valuable rewards from the Sect to further assist their cultivation."

"My! So they are basically schools for Cultivators!"

Yu Rou then turned to look at Yuan again, thinking to herself, 'If I recall correctly, brother has always expressed his desire to experience school life. Even though he cannot do that in this world, he can definitely do it in the cultivation world! Albeit it'll be different from our schools, it's better than nothing at all!'

'Good! It's decided! We'll try to join this sect together and do our best as Cultivators!' Yu Rou nodded to herself with a resolute expression on her face.

After looking around the internet for a few more minutes Yu Rou also went to bed, but since Yuan cannot feel his body and his body itself is quite fragile, she must make sure to keep a safe distance from him and even place some padding between him to make a small wall, as it would be disastrous if she accidentally rolled into him and injure his body.

Once she closed her eyes, Yu Rou fell asleep rather quickly.

—

Yu Rou woke up early in the morning, as usual, to clean herself before preparing herself for her piano lessons.

Once her morning lessons were done, Yu Rou went to prepare breakfast for Yuan.

"Good morning, Yu Rou," Yuan greeted her when she returned to the room with food in her hands.

"Good morning, brother. It feels weird to be greeting you in my own room," she chuckled.

After washing Yuan's face and brushing his teeth, Yu Rou fed him chicken soup.

"Brother, I think I know what we should do next," she said to him as she fed him.

"What do you want to do?"

"You have always wanted to experience school, right? Well, there are these places known as 'Sects' within Cultivation Online, and they are basically schools for Cultivators. I know they're not the same, but it's the only way for you to experience school right now."

"Sects? What a coincidence! I was also about to ask if you wanted to join one with me!" Yuan said in a surprised voice.

"Really? Then should we join one?" she asked.

"Of course!"

"Great! Then we should participate in the event in Spring City today!" Yu Rou said to him.

"Event? What event?"

"There's an event in Spring City where the lord of the city, the Xuan Family, will be recruiting disciples for the Dragon Essence Temple! If we pass this exam, we should be able to join this sect!"

"The Xuan Family and the Dragon Essence Temple?" If Yuan could see right now, he would be staring at Yu Rou with wide eyes filled with surprise.

What a coincidence! Not only did he plan on joining the Dragon Essence Temple in the future but he also knew the Xuan Family!

"Okay, that sounds good," Yuan said.

"Then it's decided!"

"Ah, one more thing, brother. Your room is still being cleaned by the maids, so you'll play beside me today," she said to him.

"Oh... I forgot... Your gaming helmet was also submerged in that black gunk and was tossed in the trash last night, so we'll have to get you a new one."

"What?! They threw away my gaming helmet?! What about my account? Don't tell me I'll have to create a new account! You must retrieve that helmet no matter how bad it smells!" Yuan cried out loud, his voice filled with panic. He cannot imagine what he'll do if he really has to create a new account because of this! What will happen to Xiao Hua, who is still inside the necklace? Would she remain there forever? That's terrifying to even think about!

"There's no need to panic, brother. Did you forget? You can only have one account and one character, and it doesn't matter how many times you change the gaming helmet, you'll still be able to play your character."

"Oh... right... I indeed forgot about that." Yuan said in a low voice before sighing in relief.

"Anyway, I'll go tell someone to buy one right now."

Yu Rou left the room to tell a maid to buy another console for Yuan.

About an hour later, the maid returned to Yu Rou with a brand new gaming helmet.

Once everything was prepared, Yu Rou and Yuan both laid on the same bed with the gaming helmet on their heads.

"I'll see you inside, brother." Yu Rou said to Yuan before pressing the power button on his helmet, sending him into the game first before going inside herself.

"Welcome back, Brother Yu— Tian..." Xiao Hua left the necklace a second after he logged on.

"Xiao Hua... Thank god you won't be trapped inside that necklace forever..." he sighed again after seeing her cute face.

"???" However, Xiao Hua merely looked at him with a puzzled look on her face. Why would she be trapped inside the necklace forever?

Chapter 77 - Dragon Essence Temple Exam Token

Yu Rou entered the game a few moments after Yuan.

"Are we all ready to take this exam?" Yu Rou asked them.

"Exam?" Xiao Hua looked at Yuan, as she had no idea what they were talking about.

Yuan proceeded to explain to Xiao Hua their plans for today and how they are going to partake in this exam to become disciples for the Dragon Essence Temple.

"Brother Tian is going to become a disciple for the Dragon Essence Temple? But it would be much more efficient for you to stay as a Rogue Cultivator and find resources in the wilderness than to join a Sect since you will have to compete against tens of thousands of disciples from the Sect for resources, and the resources you get are not very valuable." Xiao Hua said to him, finding his purpose quite puzzling and unnecessary.

"I know what you mean, but I am not becoming a disciple for the resources. Instead, I want to experience life as a Cultivator and see how the other Cultivators live. If I am going to become stronger as a Cultivator, I should know more about them, right?" Yuan said to her.

"..." Xiao Hua turned silent after hearing his response. Indeed, Yuan needed a better understanding of Cultivators and the cultivation world, as he was quite naive in this regard.

Sometime later, Yuan and Xiao Hua began making their way towards this exam site while being led by Yu Rou.

As they were walking, Yuan asked Xiao Hua, "Xiao Hua, can I ask you a few questions regarding cultivation? I need some advice."

"What is it, Brother Tian?" she looked at him.

"Do you know why one might feel pain all over their body when they try to cultivate? It feels like being stabbed by needles."

Hearing Yuan's words, Xiao Hua immediately frowned with a worried expression on her face.

"Brother Tian, are you feeling pain when cultivating?" She asked him, worried that it might be a side effect from eating too many monster cores.

"Eh? N-No... I am just asking," he quickly shook his head.

"Well... There are a few reasons why one would feel pain during cultivation," Xiao Hua said, and she continued, "One of them is simply because their meridians are blocked by impurities or other unnatural things. Another common reason would be damaged meridians. If one has damaged meridians, they would not be able to cultivate until healing them."

"What about a normal person who is trying to cultivate for the first time? When they try to cultivate, their body will feel intense pain, but it also feels as though they are making progress— like they are getting closer to their breakthrough."

"One's circumstances do not matter, Brother Tian. If their body experiences pain when trying to cultivate, there must be something wrong with their meridians or body," Xiao Hua said to him.

"Hmmm... Then are there any methods to help with that kind of problem?" Yuan asked.

"Yes, there are treasures that cleanses one's meridians with some even restoring them to a healthy condition. If one is having trouble trying to

become a Cultivator, there are even treasures that can forcefully assist with their breakthrough. However, since medicines and treasures that can heal or affect one's meridians are very valuable, most people won't be able to buy them."

Xiao Hua then continued, "In fact, the Seven Colored Herb in Brother Tian's possession is a key ingredient in many pill recipes that can affect one's meridians, hence why it's so sought after and valuable."

"The Seven Colored Herb, huh..."

Yuan wondered if he would be able to cultivate in the real world if he consumes these treasures that can heal his meridians.

After walking around the large city for half an hour, Yuan and the others finally reached the place of the exam, and they were able to spot it from very far away due to the large gathering that was already present there.

"Man, I can't wait to join the Dragon Essence Temple!"

"What cultivation level are you now? I just reached fifth level Spirit Apprentice!"

"Haha, since I don't have much time to play, I only managed to reach the third level today."

"What do you think the exam will look like?"

"Who knows. I have never done this before."

"Me neither."

There appeared to be a good chunk of people within the crowd that were players, and they were all filled with excitement as they waited for the exam to start.

"Wow, there's a lot of people here," Yuan exclaimed after seeing the sea of people there.

"That's to be expected, since the Dragon Essence Temple is a renowned Sect, and there are many players that still haven't joined a Sect yet." Yu Rou said to him.

Once they got closer to the area, Yuan looked around for the Xuan Family.

'I don't see Xuan Wuhan or her father... Are they going to be here later?' Yuan wondered to himself when he couldn't see their figures anywhere.

After standing around for a few minutes, a group of individuals wearing similar clothes approached the area.

"If you are here for the initial exam for the Dragon Essence Temple, make a single file line here!" The person in front of the small group— a middle-aged man with an unfriendly face shouted loudly.

Very quickly, the crowd began scrambling around.

A few minutes later, Yuan and Yu Rou managed to secure a spot somewhere in the middle of the line, but they were still behind a least a hundred people.

Once there was an orderly line that snaked around the entire area, the middle-aged man spoke loudly, "I am Elder Kang, a Sect Elder for the Outer Disciples from the Dragon Essence Temple, and I am here today to look for potential new disciples to join our sect. This is just the initial exam to see whether you are qualified to take the real exams, so you won't become a disciple for passing this exam."

"Once you qualify for this exam, you will be able to partake in the real exam directly at the Dragon Essence Temple four days from now."

"Oh... so we won't be able to experience this place together even if we pass this..." Yu Rou sighed, and she continued, "I also have school on that day, so I will miss the real examination regardless."

"Even if we can't go today, we can do it when you can play again," Yuan said to her. "I won't join the sect without you."

"No, I don't want to be a burden for you, brother. My playing schedule is very limited, so I won't be able to play with you too often. I want you to experience the Sect as a disciple even without me!"

"Are you sure...?" Yuan asked her with a slight frown on his face.

"Of course! I wanted to join the sect for you, brother! If you don't join the sect because of me, I'll feel extremely guilty about it, since that's the opposite of my intentions!" Yu Rou said to him.

After a moment of silence, Yuan nodded, "Okay, I'll join the sect."

"That's good!" Yu Rou smiled.

"Once I become a disciple, perhaps I can ask them to make an exception for you, so you will be able to become a disciple even without taking the exam!" Yuan then said to her.

"Unless you become a very important individual in the sect, I don't think they would make that kind of exception..." Yu Rou shook her head.

"There's no need to worry about that because Brother Tian will definitely become a famous disciple in no time," Xiao Hua said to her.

With Yuan's talents, he could easily become a Core Disciple for the Dragon Essence Temple.

"Is that so...?" Yu Rou mumbled, wondering where her confidence was coming from.

While her brother may be exceptionally talented, there are countless geniuses in the cultivation world, and a prominent place such as the Dragon Essence Temple will surely have a few geniuses that could rival Yuan, right? After all, there is a saying 'there's always someone better than you'.

After standing in the line for half an hour, it was finally Yuan's turn to take the exam.

"Name?" Elder Kang asked Yuan without looking at him, keeping his own gaze on the clipboard in his hands.

"Yu Tian," he said.

"What's your cultivation level and age?" Elder Kang then asked in an uninterested tone, almost like he didn't want to be there.

"..."

Yuan immediately hesitated.

"F-Fifth Level Spirit Apprentice, 18 years old," he decided to lie.

'Fifth Level Spirit Apprentice?' Yu Rou looked at him with raised eyebrows and a suspicious gaze. Although she cannot see his cultivation level, surely he must be above Fifth Level Spirit Apprentice, right? After all, he'd defeated four players at the same level with ease!

"Yu Tian, Fifth Level Spirit Apprentice, 18 years old..." Elder Kang wrote his name and age on the clipboard without even looking at him.

"Place your hands on the crystal ball behind me. If it glows green, you pass. Next!"

Yuan nodded and went to touch the crystal ball that was managed by the disciples that came with Elder Kang.

A few moments later, the crystal ball glowed a bright green.

"Congratulations, you pass. Take this token. You'll need it for the real exam. Without it, you won't be able to partake in the examination so don't lose it." The disciple said to Yuan before handing him a small jade token.

«You have obtained 'Dragon Essence Temple Exam Token'»

"Thank you," Yuan said to them before leaving the place with the others.

"You're not going to take the exams, Xiao Hua?" Yu Rou asked her afterward.

"No," Xiao Hua shook her head.

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Chapter 78 - Center Of Attention

"Why not? Aren't you going to the sect with Brother Tian?" Yu Rou raised her eyebrows.

"Xiao Hua follows Brother Tian wherever he goes," she quickly nodded.

"How will you follow my brother into the sect if you're not a disciple?" Yu Rou asked.

"Xiao Hua can follow Brother Tian as a servant since disciples are allowed to have servants with them," she responded.

"S-Servant...?" Yu Rou looked at her with wide eyes. However, while Xiao Hua called herself a servant, Yu Rou did not think about the 'pet' system and took her words quite literally as a servant like the maids in their Yu Family's household.

"By the way, what should we do now that we cannot join the sect instantly? Should we just return to doing quests?" Yuan asked a moment later.

"Hmmm... I want to learn the technique we just bought, but I don't want to spend too much time on it..." Yu Rou sighed.

"It's okay. Have some confidence in yourself, Yu Rou. After all, you're also a genius yourself," Yuan said to her with a gentle smile on his face.

"Brother..." Yu Rou nodded a moment later.

"Xiao Hua, do you know of a good place where she can practice silently? Should we return to Cultivators' Haven?" Yuan decided to ask her.

"No, there are better places for learning techniques," she said. "Just like how there are formations that can speed up your cultivation speed, there are also formations that can help with your comprehension. However, it doesn't actually boost one's comprehension skill— only create an atmosphere where one can concentrate much easier."

"That sounds like the perfect place for learning techniques! What is this place called?" Yu Rou spoke with excitement in her voice.

"Pagoda of Tranquility," Xiao Hua said.

"Pagoda of Tranquility? I don't think there's a building in this city with that name..." Yu Rou said.

"That's because there isn't one in Spring City. If you want to go to that place, there's one in Nature City, which is about 1,00 miles away."

"1,000 miles!? It'll take us days to get there!" Yu Rou exclaimed.

"It'll only take a few hours if we fly there," Xiao Hua said.

"F-Fly...?" Yu Rou looked at her with wide eyes filled with surprise.

Xiao Hua nodded with a calm expression on her face before she started levitating in the air.

"Y-You're really flying!" Yu Rou then turned to look at Yuan and asked him, "D-Did you know about this?!"

"Hm? Pretty much." Yuan nodded.

Then he continued, "But how are we supposed to take her with us? I don't think she can use the flying sword even with your help."

"Brother Tian can carry her," Xiao Hua said.

"Hmm... I guess that could work..." Yuan nodded.

He then retrieved the flying sword and waited for Xiao Hua to support it with her spiritual energy.

"I'm going to carry you now, Yu Rou," Yuan said as he lifted Yu Rou's entire body effortlessly.

"B-Brother?!" Yu Rou's face immediately flushed with redness when Yuan suddenly carried her princess-style.

"Hold still, Yu Rou!" Yuan said to her as he jumped onto the flying sword.

'This is a bit awkward, but I should manage...' Yuan thought to himself as he adjusted his balance and posture.

"Are we ready to go, Brother Tian?" Xiao Hua asked him.

"Yes, go ahead, but don't go too fast." Yuan nodded.

A moment later, Xiao Hua flew towards the bright sky whilst controlling the flying sword.

"Look! Immortals!"

The pedestrians pointed at their disappearing figure with awe on their faces, and the Players watched with dazed looks, hoping they would be able to do the same in the future.

"Aaaaaaaaah!!!" Yu Rou screamed with her eyes closed when they suddenly started moving, not daring to open them even many moments later, and her arms were tightly wrapped around Yuan's neck.

"Are you okay, Yu Rou?" Yuan asked her with a smile on his face. "You won't fall, so don't worry."

However, Yu Rou still refused to open her eyes until many minutes later when she was finally getting used to the feeling of flying in the air, but her slender arms remained hugging Yuan's neck tightly.

"Wow..." Yu Rou looked at the passing scenery with her eyes filled with wonder.

"What do you think, Yu Rou? Isn't this world beautiful?" Yuan asked her a moment later.

"Yes!" Yu Rou said.

After looking at the scenery for a few minutes, Yu Rou turned to look at Yuan, who held a gentle smile on his handsome face as he carried her like some kind of prince, and Yu Rou's gaze would remain on his face for the next few minutes.

"Hm? What's the matter?" Yuan looked at her and asked after realizing that she was staring intensely at him.

"N-Nothing!" Yu Rou quickly said in a startled voice, feeling her heart rate skyrocketing afterward.

"A-Actually, I wanted to ask about Xiao Hua... How come she can fly? What cultivation is she at?"

"Uhhh... Spirit...King?" Yuan responded in a weird tone.

"Spirit King? What cultivation level is that?" Yu Rou raised her eyebrows in a puzzled manner.

"I think it's like five realms above the Spirit Apprentice realm?"

"W-Wait! Five realms above me?! That's ridiculously high! And you had someone powerful like her following you around this entire time?! You can literally do anything in this game if you wanted with her around!" Yu Rou stared at him with a shocked gaze, and even more questions appeared inside her head.

How come someone as powerful as Xiao Hua is following him around?
Who is Xiao Hua, exactly?

Yu Rou narrowed her eyes at Yuan with a suspicious gaze, and she asked him, "Brother... I have been meaning to ask you this question for a while now, but what is your in-game name?"

"..."

Yuan's body immediately stiffened after hearing her question, and his back and hands quickly became sweaty.

'Haaa... Why did I pick 'Yuan' as my name? What if she learns about 'that' because of this? I don't want to lose her...' Yuan sighed inwardly.

"Brother? Are you okay? Why aren't you saying anything? It's just your in-game name. There's no need to be so secretive..." Yu Rou said to him a moment later, her suspicions growing even stronger.

"..."

'I could lie to her, but she will learn the truth sooner or later— about my name and 'that', and I cannot bear the guilt of lying straight to her face... not after everything that she's done— sacrificed for me...'

After seeing the perplexed expression on Yuan's face, Yu Rou said, "It's okay, brother. Although I don't know the reason, you don't have to tell me if you don't want to. I can wait until you are ready to tell me."

"No, it's okay." Yuan suddenly said. "I'll tell you."

"Are you sure? You don't have to force yourself..."

"While there are a few reasons why I don't want to say it, you are my precious little sister, and I simply can't say no to you," Yuan said with a bittersweet on his face.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan spoke in a slightly shaky voice, "In this world, I have given myself the name 'Yuan'..."

"Yuan...?" Yu Rou looked at him with wide eyes filled with surprise, but she was not shocked. In fact, she was feeling somewhat relieved.

After staring at Yuan for a good minute, Yu Rou turned to look at Xiao Hua, who was staring back at her with a silent gaze.

Yu Rou then closed her eyes and took a deep breath before speaking in a surprisingly calm voice, "I see... so you were Player Yuan this entire time."

"I'm sorry for trying to hide it from you, Yu Rou. It's just that there are many people who are angry at me and trying to hunt me for some reason, and I didn't want you to think of me as some villain or someone who is hated by others..."

Yu Rou shook her head and even caressed his cheeks with her hand, "Don't be silly, brother. I don't care what the others think about you, and even if the entire world is against you, I would never hate you. After all, you are still my precious brother who was always there when I needed someone..."

She then continued, "And I think I know the reason why so many people are trying to hunt you, so you don't need to worry about that."

"Really? Why?" Yuan asked her.

"It's simple, brother. They are jealous of you— of your talents. No matter if it's the real world or in video games, there will always be people who will be envious of your talents, so you shouldn't pay too much attention to them."

"Anyway, as expected of you, brother. Not only did you shock the world with your talents in the real world but you are also causing quite the commotion in the gaming scene. No matter where you go, whether you are aware or not, you are always in some kind of spotlight."

"Haha... you are exaggerating, Yu Rou..."

"Whether I am exaggerating or not, it is a fact that you have once again become the center of attention across the world. Although the world may no longer care about the name 'Yu Tian' after you disappeared from the entertainment world, everybody is currently paying attention to the name 'Yuan' and watching your every step, so make sure you don't let them

down, brother. Of course, I will also be watching you." Yu Rou said to him with a smile on her beautiful face.

"Un." Yuan nodded.

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Chapter 79 - Pagoda Of Tranquility

'So Brother Tian is actually the mysterious Player Yuan, huh...' Yu Rou thought to herself with a subtle smile on her face as she rested her head on Yuan's chest as they soared across the sky on a flying sword. 'No wonder why I was so interested in his identity. Maybe I somehow knew that it was my brother, hence why I took interest in him in the first place...'

'As for Player Yuan being a little girl, it must be Xiao Hua that they're talking about since they are always together. How did they even mistake her for my brother?'

'If mother and father learn about this, they will probably be shocked... but I cannot tell them, or they might try to take advantage of brother again, and I cannot allow him to suffer anymore...'

Yu Rou lifted her head slightly to look at Yuan's handsome face again, and he looked much better than before, as he felt as though the invisible mountain on his shoulders had disappeared after telling Yu Rou the truth.

'Player Yuan... the only player in the world with a Divine-grade and Heaven-grade technique... He also has a Divine-grade servant... Hmm?'

Yu Rou suddenly realized something, and she opened her mouth to speak, "Brother, you have a Divine-grade servant right? What does it look like? Can you summon it for me to see later?"

"Uhh..." Yuan turned to look at Xiao Hua and said, "I'm pretty sure you have already met her..."

Yu Rou also turned to look at Xiao Hua, her gaze filled with shock.

"What?! Xiao Hua is the Divine-grade Servant?! Humans can also be Servants?! I had no idea that was even possible!" Yu Rou exclaimed after learning this shocking information.

"No wonder why she's following you around despite her crazy cultivation level! You sure are lucky to find someone like her, brother!" Yu Rou said to him.

However, Xiao Hua shook her head and said, "No, Xiao Hua is the lucky one to have met Brother Tian."

"You can call me Yuan again, Xiao Hua," Yuan said to her.

"Okay, Brother Yuan." Xiao Hua nodded, feeling more familiar with this name.

"Brother, can you tell me about your adventures as Yuan?" Yu Rou asked him sometime later, and she continued, "I would love to know the story behind Player Yuan's achievements."

Yuan nodded and said, "Of course."

He proceeded to tell her about his adventure since he started the game. He began the story with how he met Xiao Hua. Then he told her about his encounter with these two experts fighting each other in the sky before his adventures at the Flying Sword Sect. Then he recalled what happened at the auction house and how he managed to unlock the Wealth Leaderboards, becoming the richest player in the game instantly. He told her about the dangers of this world and how he encountered and killed the Demonic Spider. And lastly, he spoke about what happened at Pang City and how he defended the city from tens of thousands of monsters, eventually slaying the Mountain Lord and becoming the hero of an entire city.

Yu Rou held a shocked face as she listened to his ridiculous story that sounded like a fantasy, yet her heart was filled with admiration for Yuan, who managed to achieve so many unbelievable things in such a short time.

"What a crazy adventure you've experienced, brother. It's like you started your adventure in the endgame while everyone else started from the very beginning. If not for you, I would still be doing gathering quests right now and probably for the rest of the week."

"What about your goals, brother? What do you hope to achieve in this game?" Yu Rou then asked him.

"I originally wanted to just explore this world at my own pace and have fun together with you, but now..." Yuan paused for a moment before continuing, "I want to become strong and raise my cultivation base so that nobody can bully us like what happened when those players tried to rob us."

"Then my goal is to become strong enough so that I won't slow you down, Mr. Player Yuan!" Yu Rou chuckled.

Yuan smiled and said, "Like I said, Yu Rou. You don't have to worry about that. I'll play with you regardless of how far you are behind, and I am also going to do my best to assist you."

"Un! Now that I know your real identity, I won't be humble about it any longer!" she laughed.

A few hours later, they reached Nature City, landing a few miles from the city because Yu Rou didn't want them to attract too much attention with their flying abilities.

After paying the entrance fees, Yu Rou asked the guards by the entrance, "Do you know where Pagoda of Tranquility is?"

"Yes, if you walk straight down this road, you will arrive at this 3-story pagoda in about 10 minutes." One of the guards quickly answered her question with a slightly bashful expression on his face after seeing Yu Rou's pretty face.

"Thank you!" Yu Rou said with a blinding smile, and the guard felt as though an arrow had pierced his heart.

Once they knew which way to go, Yuan and the other two began making their way to the Pagoda of Tranquility.

Sometime later, they arrived at this luxurious pagoda that gave a similar atmosphere to Cultivators' Haven.

"Let's go inside," Yuan said as he entered the building.

"Welcome to Pagoda of Tranquility! How many I help you all today?" The receptionist behind the counter waved at them.

"I'd like to rent a room," Yuan said.

"Which floor would you like a room in? The higher floors will have a higher quality formation, improving the effects and your concentration."

"The best room you have available," Yuan responded without hesitation.

"We have three rooms available on the third floor, and that would be 10 gold coins per hour." The receptionist said.

'Only 10 gold per hour? This is much cheaper than Cultivators' Haven!' Yuan thought to himself.

"Let me get 2 rooms, 10 hours each," he said a moment later.

"That would be 200 gold coins," said the receptionist.

Yuan nodded and handed him the money.

"May I know your names?"

"Yu Tian, Yu Rou, and Xiao Hua," he said.

A few moments later, after writing their names down, the receptionist handed them two keys.

"Thank you for coming to our Pagoda of Tranquility." The receptionist bowed to them before they went upstairs.

Once they were on the third floor, Yu Rou said to Yuan, "Brother, I am going to spend 4 hours and see if I can learn it by then."

"Don't worry, Yu Rou. You can spend as much time as you need, and knowing your talents, I am confident that you'll learn it in no time," Yuan said to her.

Yu Rou nodded and went into one of the available rooms that had a wooden door instead of a boulder this time, as learning techniques did not require as much peace and silence as one would during cultivation.

Once Yu Rou was inside the room, she immediately sat down on the floor and retrieved the Wind Blade technique from her storage pouch, and she began studying it with a serious expression on her face.

Meanwhile, inside Yuan's room, he was sitting in the lotus position as Xiao Hua recited Heaven's Secret Art for him. Even though he does not have any new techniques to learn, he was nowhere near mastering the Divine-grade technique, and he wanted to take this chance to improve his understanding as much as possible.

'If I have a better understanding of this technique, I might be able to finally cultivate in the real world, too.' Yuan thought to himself as he closed his eyes and listened to Xiao Hua recite the technique for him.

Four hours passed in the blink of an eye, and Yu Rou knocked on Yuan's door.

"How did it go, Yu Rou? Did you learn the technique?" Yuan asked her after opening the door.

"No," she shook her head, and she continued, "But I am getting very close to understanding it! I just need a few more hours!"

"Take as long as you need, Yu Rou. If 10 hours isn't enough, I'll pay for more." Yuan said to her.

"It's alright, brother. I should learn the technique with the remaining 6 hours left!" She spoke with confidence written all over her face before she returned to her own room and continued to study the technique.

Yuan also returned to listening to Xiao Hua's voice shortly later.

A few hours later.

«Your comprehension for Heaven's Secret Art has reached a new level»

«Heaven's Secret Art Mastery Level (2) → (3)»

«You have learned Heaven's Third Secret Art — Heavenly Domain»

Heavenly Domain

Rank: Divine

Mastery Level: 1

Description: Holding absolute authority within your domain, dominate the battlefield, and pressure your enemies with the Heavenly Domain!

"Heavenly Domain..." Yuan mumbled in a low voice after learning this technique.

"Congratulations, Brother Yuan. You are only in the Spirit Warrior realm, but your understanding of Heaven's Secret Art is already near Xiao Hua's level. It's almost like this technique was made for you." Xiao Hua said to him afterward.

"Thank you, Xiao Hua. This array below us is amazing. My mind is much clearer than normal, allowing me to concentrate even more." Yuan said to her.

"Anyway, even though there's still some time before our time is over, let's leave for now and wait for Yu Rou to finish."

Yuan and Xiao Hua left the room shortly later and proceeded to stand outside Yu Rou's room, patiently waiting for her to finish her last hour inside the room.

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Chapter 80 - Results

«You have learned Wind Blade»

Wind Blade

Rank: Mortal

Mastery Level: 1

Description: Summon wind blades that can attack foes from a distance.
Requires at least 500 Qi to activate.

"Yes! I finally managed to learn it!" Yu Rou exclaimed in excitement after seeing the notification, feeling relieved that she did not have to waste any more time on it.

"How much time do I have left in this room?" Yu Rou turned to look at the timer beside the door.

"10 minutes left?!" Her eyes widened with surprise after seeing that it'd taken her nearly 10 hours to learn a single Mortal-rank technique.

"I really cannot compare to Brother Tian who can learn techniques as easy as breathing," she sighed loudly.

After storing the Wind Blade technique into her storage pouch, Yu Rou went outside to knock on Yuan's door, but to her surprise, he was already outside and waiting for her.

"Brother... When did you come out? I didn't make you wait too long, right?" she asked him.

"No, we just came out," he said with a smile.

"Anyway, how did it go? Were you able to learn the technique?"

"Un!" Yu Rou nodded with a bright smile. "I barely managed to learn it in those 10 hours!"

"Congratulations, Yu Rou," Yuan said.

"I am nothing compared to you, brother." Yu Rou shook her head.

"That's not true," he said.

"You don't need to try and comfort me, brother. I have known very well about the difference between our talents for years now— this is nothing new." Yu Rou said, and she continued, "Anyway, now that I have learned a new technique, I would like to use it, so let's go hunting some monsters!"

Yuan nodded, "Okay, where do you want to go?"

"Anywhere that has low-level monsters, preferably ones around the first level to second level Spirit Apprentice," she said.

"There are plenty of beasts below the third level Spirit Apprentice a few miles from this city," Xiao Hua said.

"Great! Then let's go!" Yu Rou said.

They proceeded to walk downstairs and returned the keys to the receptionist before leaving the building.

Once they were outside, Yuan retrieved his flying sword and jumped onto it with Yu Rou in his arms.

A few moments later, they soared towards the sky and flew for a few minutes until they were a couple of miles away from Nature City.

"There are a few first-level Spirit Apprentice beasts below us," Xiao Hua said to them.

"Oh! I want to fight them!" Yu Rou said.

Xiao Hua nodded, and they descended to the ground a moment later.

"Where is it?" Yu Rou asked after they landed.

"200 meters that way." Xiao Hua pointed south.

"Okay!"

Yu Rou proceeded to walk in that direction with wide strides, clearly impatient to try out her new skill.

"Slow down, Yu Rou. The monsters aren't going anywhere," Yuan said to her with a smile after seeing her excitement.

A few moments later, Yu Rou could finally see the monster; it was a slightly oversized fox with orange fur and red eyes.

"That's a Red-eyed Fox. They are nimble but weak. If you don't hit it with your first strike, you won't have a second chance because it will run away," Xiao Hua said in a low voice.

Yu Rou nodded and retrieved her Spirit Waver.

After taking a deep breath, she gathered her spiritual energy before waving her fan a moment later.

"Wind Blade!"

An arc of wind resembling long-distance sword attacks suddenly flew from the Spirit Waver and at the Red-eyed Fox.

However, because this is Yu Rou's first time using the skill and the Spirit Waver, her aim was way off target, missing the Red-eyed fox by a long shot.

Bang!

The Wind Blade did a weird turn in the air before flying into a tree and destroying it with ease.

When the Red-eyed Fox saw this, it immediately turned around and ran away.

"Wow... No wonder why this skill cost so much despite being a Mortal-rank technique! It's really powerful!" Yu Rou's eyes flickered with excitement after seeing the skill's destructive power.

"The strength is comparable to a technique at the Earth-rank technique," Xiao Hua said to her.

And she continued, "If it doesn't hit the target, it won't matter even if the technique is the strongest in the world, though."

"I know, but it's actually very hard to control this skill." Yu Rou sighed.

"Unless you're Brother Yuan, one would normally require many hours of training before they can use a newly learned technique properly."

"Even if I have to practice for hundreds of hours, I am going to perfect this skill that my brother bought me!" Yu Rou said with a resolute expression on her face.

Sometime later, they continued to hunt low-level monsters with Xiao Hua giving the directions and Yu Rou trying her best to hit her targets.

An hour and countless misses later, Yu Rou finally managed to hit her target with Wind Blade, brutally cutting the monster in half as it did to the tree before.

"Uwa... Isn't this technique like... a little too powerful?" Yu Rou realized this after she witnessed how the monster nearly exploded into a bloody mess.

"Isn't it a good thing that the technique's powerful?" Yuan tilted his head, not understanding her worries.

"I mean, of course, but it's a little too brutal for my taste." Yu Rou sighed. How can an elegant young lady like her use such a savage technique? It would definitely ruin her graceful image!

"Then do you want a new technique?" Yuan asked her.

"No, this is fine. It may be a brutal technique, but I don't dislike it. I just need to get used to the scene of my opponents being torn apart by the skill." Yu Rou said.

"Anyway, let's continue hunting monsters. The only way I can get better with this skill is by using it over and over again! Therefore— onto the next monster, Xiao Hua!" Yu Rou pointed in a random direction with her fan with a profound expression on her face.

"Okay..." Xiao Hua nodded.

And for the next few hours, until it was time for dinner, Yu Rou would hunt monsters continuously using her Wind Blade whilst Xiao Hua led her around the wilderness.

As for Yuan, he merely followed them in silence. However, it was not as though he was completely relaxed, as he still had to make sure that no harm would come to Yu Rou, so whenever they approach a monster, he would mentally prepare himself just in case he needed to step in and protect Yu Rou.

"Brother, I have hunted so many monsters, yet not one of them dropped a single monster core, why is that?" Yu Rou asked him at the end of their adventure.

"That's because only monsters above seventh level Spirit Apprentice drop them," he responded. "Did I get that right, Xiao Hua?" he asked her just in case.

"That's right," she nodded.

"Seventh level Spirit Apprentice, huh? That's a long way..." Yu Rou sighed.

"Anyways, I am going to log off now to cook dinner, brother. You can play a little longer until dinner is ready if you like."

"No, it's fine. There's nothing I can do in this area in such a short time, anyways."

"Then I'll see you on the other side," Yu Rou said to him before logging off.

"I'll see you tomorrow, Xiao Hua."

"Un. Goodbye, Brother Yuan." Xiao Hua said to him before disappearing into the necklace.

Yuan also logged off shortly later.

Once he was in the real world again and Yu Rou left to prepare dinner, Yuan began trying to cultivate again, hoping that he would have better results after his understanding of the cultivation technique had improved.

"..."

"..."

"..."

"...Ouch!"

Yuan tried to cultivate many times without any progress until Yu Rou returned with the food.

"Are you okay, brother? I heard you yelling in pain just now..." Yu Rou said to him in a worried voice.

"Hm? Oh, it's nothing." Yuan said, not prepared to tell her about trying to cultivate in the real world just yet— at least not until he confirms that it actually works and he's not just going crazy.

"If you feel any pain in your body, don't hesitate to let me know, okay?" Yu Rou said to him afterward.

"Don't worry, I won't," Yuan said.

"Good. Anyway, I have some news. Doctor Wang will be coming later, and he said that he has some results regarding the black gunk that discharged from your body."

"Okay," Yuan said.

"Let's fill your stomach before he arrives," Yu Rou said as she began feeding him chicken soup.

Sometime later, Doctor Wang arrived at their home, and Yu Rou greeted him with Yuan in the wheelchair.

"You have the results already, Doctor Wang? That was quicker than I'd anticipated," Yu Rou said to him.

"Well, I worked without stopping for nearly the entire day to get the results as soon as possible, and you won't believe what I found from the examination," Doctor Wang said.

"What is it? Is it something we should be worried about?" Yu Rou asked him with a nervous expression.

"Actually, it should be the opposite! According to the results, the black gunks are actually impurities! Although I don't know how it happened, it appears that the Young Master has managed to discharge the impurities within his body."

"Impurities...?" Yu Rou raised her eyebrows. What does that even mean?

"Sit down, Young Lady. This is going to take some time to explain," Doctor Wang said to her.

Yu Rou nodded, and she went to grab a chair before sitting down and waiting for Doctor Wang to continue.

Chapter 81 - Player Yuan's Sister

Chapter 81 - Player Yuan's Sister

"Before we begin, I should let you know that this is based on one ancient medicine book I read in the past, as this is the first time something like this has happened in our medical history," Doctor Wang said with a serious expression.

"Ancient medicine book?" Yu Rou raised her eyebrows, unsure of how to feel about this.

"Yes, the black gunk that came out of the Young Master's body are impurities— filth that gathers in one's body over time— similar to the filth that gathers on one's face and their pores naturally, but this impurity is much more filthy and impotent, and it is something that normally cannot be cleaned from one's body, as it gathers deep within your body."

"Then why did it happen to my brother?" Yu Rou asked afterward.

"Honestly, I don't know." Doctor Wang shook his head, feeling a little shameful that he had to say such words as one of the best doctors in the world.

"Not even that ancient medicine book mentioned anything?"

"Unfortunately."

Yu Rou looked at her brother before continuing, "Then why do you say it's a good thing?"

"Because the impurities are harmful to one's body. Although it won't kill us, it is obviously better for our body to get rid of its impurities." Doctor Wang said.

"So everybody has these impurities, right?"

"That's correct. You, me, and everyone in this world should have these impurities within our body, and there is nothing we can do to it unless what happened to the Young Master happens to us too." Doctor Wang nodded.

"Anyway, that's all I have for the results. However, I have another reason for coming here today. Young Master, would you mind visiting my hospital tomorrow so I can scan your body to make sure there's nothing wrong with it?"

"What do you think, Yu Rou?" Yuan asked her.

"We'll lose some time playing together, but your well-being is more important to me, so we can go tomorrow," Yu Rou said.

"Then it's decided." Doctor Wang nodded his head. "I will see you tomorrow."

"See you tomorrow, Doctor Wang!"

Once Doctor Wang left, Yu Rou helped Yuan brush his teeth before tucking him into her bed. Even though his own room is already clean, the foul smell still lingered, and they will need to wait a few more days to let it disappear naturally.

As Yuan slept on her bed, Yu Rou surfed the web. However, unlike previously, whenever she sees 'Player Yuan' being mentioned on the forums, a proud smile would appear on her face.

'Hahaha... now that I know my brother is actually Player Yuan, seeing these people speculate and talk about him is a hundred times more entertaining!' Yu Rou laughed inwardly as she read everything about Player Yuan even more intensively than before.

After spending many minutes looking at people talking about her brother, Yu Rou suddenly had the desire to post something herself, so she created a

brand new account under the alias 'Player Yuan's Sister' and posted on the forum with the title 'I am Player Yuan's Sister, Ask Me Anything'.

"Let's see what kind of questions I'll get," Yu Rou waited in anticipation.

And not even a minute after she made her post, someone has already commented on her post.

[If you are Player Yuan's sister then I am Player Yuan's father! Hahaha!]

"Well, it's not as though I didn't expect these kinds of comments since I also wouldn't believe it if someone with a brand new account claimed to be Player Yuan's sister." Yu Rou shook her head with a smile.

And by the time Yu Rou finished reading the first comment, another comment was made on her post.

[Brand new account claiming to be Player Yuan's sister— Kinda sus...]

And then another—

[If you are really Player Yuan's sister, prove it.]

[Are you delusional? Who would believe you?]

[What a bad troll!]

Yu Rou shook her head at these rightfully suspicious replies before closing her computer and going to sleep.

'Well, even if they asked legit questions, I wouldn't answer them seriously, anyway.' Yu Rou thought to herself as she laid beside Yuan who was already deeply asleep.

'If the world learns about my brother's identity, they might take him away from me, and I cannot allow that to happen no matter what...' Yu Rou thought to herself as she fell asleep.

—

The following morning, after Yu Rou finished her piano lessons and fed Yuan breakfast, she prepared to go to the hospital with Yuan.

"Are you ready, brother?" Yu Rou asked him, who was sitting in the wheelchair wearing formal clothes she specifically picked.

"Whenever you are," he said.

"Then let's go," Yu Rou nodded as she began pushing the wheelchair.

And by the time they left the house, there was already a black limousine waiting in the front with four guards wearing black uniforms standing around it.

"Where will we be heading today, Young Lady?" One of the guards asked her.

"Doctor Wang's hospital," she calmly responded.

Another guard opened the door of the limousine for them.

Once Yu Rou carried Yuan inside the limousine, the guard folded the wheelchair and stored it inside the trunk, before going sitting inside with them.

A few moments later, the limousine began moving, quickly leaving the sight of the mansion behind them.

Inside the limousine, Yuan was laying on the long seat with his body strapped so he doesn't fall and his head resting on Yu Rou's lap.

"How are you feeling right now, brother?" Yu Rou asked him.

"It's been a few months since I left the house, so I'm a little bit excited," Yuan said with a smile on his face.

"Excited, huh? I would be too if we weren't going to the hospital..." Yu Rou said with a bittersweet smile on her beautiful face.

The place turned silent, and Yu Rou continuously caressed Yuan's soft and silky long hair until they reached their destination half an hour later.

"We're here, Young Lady." The guards said to her as he opened the door.

Once the other guard retrieved the wheelchair, Yu Rou carried Yuan to the wheelchair, not even asking the guards for help. In fact, the guards were aware of Yu Rou's strict rules when it came to touching Yuan, as she would not allow anyone to touch him unless permitted.

By the time Yu Rou and Yuan started approaching the large hospital a few meters away, Doctor Wang was already waiting at the entrance in his doctor uniform. However, he was not alone, as there was another individual standing beside him—a beautiful young lady around the same age as Yuan.

"Young Lady, Young Master, thank you for coming," Doctor Wang said to them with a smile on his face, and he continued, "My granddaughter heard you siblings were coming, so she decided to visit today."

"Hello, Lady Yu, Young Master! It's been a while since we last met!" The beautiful young lady waved at them with a bright smile on her face.

"It has been a while indeed, Wang Xiuying," Yu Rou said with a somewhat stiff smile on her face.

"You can talk with them after we go somewhere more private," Doctor Wang said.

"Do you need some help, Lady Yu? I can help you push the Young Master if you're tired," Wang Xiuying said to Yu Rou when she got close.

"Thank you for the offer, but I will kindly decline since I don't want to bother you with it," Yu Rou said, still with a smile on her face.

"Don't worry about bothering me. You are currently at the hospital, and it is my job as a nurse to assist the patients," Wang Xiuying responded.

"..."

Despite having a smile on her face, Yu Rou seemed a bit annoyed at Wang Xiuying's approaches, mostly because she knew that Wang Xiuying was a huge fan of Yuan when he was still actively playing the instruments.

"Xiuying, I know you are excited to see your idol, but don't get too excited. You can talk to him later," Doctor Wang shook his head at her.

And he continued a moment later, "Anyway, follow me."

Yu Rou then pushed the wheelchair and followed Doctor Wang.

Wang Xiuying, however, waited until Yu Rou and Yuan caught up before walking with them.

"Young Master Yu Tian, do you remember me?" Wang Xiuying spoke as they walked.

"I wouldn't forget your cheerful voice even if I wanted to, Miss Wang," Yuan said with a smile on his face.

"Please, you can just call me Xiuying like my grandfather does," she said.

"Anyway, I heard you are going to get an x-ray today. Are you okay?"

"Yes, I am fine. It's just that something happened a few days ago, so we're here for an examination just in case," Yuan said.

"I see... Well, whatever happened, I hope it's nothing serious or bad."

"Thank you for worrying about me."

"Hehe. As your number one fan, of course, I would worry about your well-being. Even if you cannot play the instrument anymore, I will still continue to be your number one fan for the rest of my life!" Wang Xiuying said to him without feeling bashful.

"..."

Meanwhile, despite her calm expression, Yu Rou glared at Wang Xiuying with a cold gaze from the corner of her eyes.

Wang Xiuying had noticed Yu Rou's cold glares long ago, but she acted as though she wasn't aware and continued to speak with Yuan.

Meanwhile, Doctor Wang could feel a spine-chilling atmosphere coming from behind him, and he continued walking without daring to look back, even walking a little faster than before.

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Chapter 82 - Legendary Child Prodigy

"Hey, look over there! Isn't that Doctor Wang and his granddaughter? Who are those two youngsters following them? They must be really important people if they are getting treated by the Divine Doctor himself..."

When the other patients and even some workers in the hospital noticed Yu Rou and Yuan following Doctor Wang, they immediately began gossiping with each other, as it was incredibly rare to see Doctor Wang working personally in the hospital.

"Ah, you must be new here. That's the Yu Family, they're one of the largest donors for our hospital, and Doctor Wang is currently taking care of one of their children, who has this incurable illness." One of the more experienced workers there explained to the new nurse.

"Wait a second... Did you just say the Yu Family?! That famous family with an immeasurable presence in the entertainment industry, especially the music industry? If I recall correctly, they have a genius musician in nearly every generation!"

"That's right— they are that Yu Family."

"Amazing! Then that beautiful young lady just now must be Yu Rou— the genius pianist who placed 3rd in the national piano competition at only 16 years old! I knew she looked familiar! She looks even prettier in person than she does on television! What about that young man in the wheelchair? I don't recognize him."

"Since you know Yu Rou, you definitely know that young man. Although he looks completely different now due to the illness that devastated his body, he's Yu Tian—the child prodigy."

"Wait! That's Yu Tian?! The legendary child prodigy who could play literally every instrument in the world before 10 years old with countless golden trophies under his belt? I wouldn't have known if you didn't tell me!"

"Yes, it's truly a pity that he was struck with that illness, or he would've been the greatest musician in history."

"I haven't seen him ever since he disappeared from television, almost like he'd disappeared from the world. He was still playing the instruments perfectly while blind when I last saw him on television."

"I guess even the Heavens envied him, so they decided to punish him. Haaa... I would be willing to do anything if I can see him on the stage once again..."

"Me too..."

While the nurses talked about the Yu Family's legacy, Yuan and the others just reached their destination.

"Just put the Young Master on the x-ray table whenever you are ready," Doctor Wang said to Yu Rou.

"Here, let me help you," Wang Xiuying said to Yu Rou.

"...Thank you."

Even though Yu Rou could've done it by herself, she didn't stop Wang Xiuying from helping.

After all, as much as she hated other women getting close to her brother, she simply couldn't deny someone as cheerful and kind as Wang Xiuying, who is one of the few people in this world that still respected her brother despite his tragedy.

Once Yuan was on the table, Yu Rou and Wang Xiuying left the room and went to the other room, where they could watch Yuan from behind a glass window.

"I am going to start now, Young Master." Doctor Wang spoke into the microphone that broadcasted his voice into Yuan's room before typing a few things into the computer beside him.

The x-ray machine suddenly activated, and Yuan was sent into this egg-shaped capsule for scanning.

And since the scanning process required some time, Wang Xiuying decided to play some music on her phone.

"..."

When Yu Rou heard the piano music that flowed flawlessly from her phone, she turned to look at Wang Xiuying and asked, "Is that all you ever listen to?"

"Pretty much!" she nodded without hesitation.

"Although I also listen to other music created by the Young Master, I like this masterpiece the most."

"..."

Yu Rou had nothing else to say so she remained silent for the rest of the time, even enjoying the music that was being repeated in a loop by Wang Xiuying, as it was music that was played by Yuan.

Sometime later, Yuan was pulled out of the capsule, and while Doctor Wang read the results, Yu Rou went to put Yuan back in the wheelchair.

"How is my brother, Doctor Wang?" Yu Rou asked after returning with Yuan.

"Hmmm..." After a moment of silence, he said, "As I had already expected, there's nothing wrong with the Young Master's body, so you don't have to

worry about the impurities."

"I see... that's great." Yu Rou sighed in relief after hearing the results.

"However, that is not all I have to say," Doctor Wang suddenly continued, and he said, "According to the results, the Young Master's bones... they have gotten stronger— denser than before."

"Huh? My bones have gotten denser?" Yuan spoke in a surprised voice. He wondered if this was also caused by the game.

"Yes... Although it's not that much denser than before, it's definitely improved enough to be noticed."

"Well, it doesn't matter how much stronger my bones grow if I can't use them," Yuan laughed in a bitter voice.

"Don't give up, Young Master. The heavens won't abandon a genius such as yourself if they favored you enough to give you such talents. I'm sure this is only temporary, and if my grandfather can't heal you, I'll definitely try to do something!" Wang Xiuying spoke with enthusiasm.

"Yeah, yeah, let's see how that works out for you when all you are doing nowadays is play video games..." Doctor Wang shook his head.

"I can still study medicine as I play video games! In fact, I have learned a bunch about ancient medicine in the game that I am currently playing!" Wang Xiuying said to him.

"Ancient medicine...? Are you also playing Cultivation Online?" Yuan suddenly asked her.

"Eh?" Wang Xiuying turned to look at him with a surprised expression on her face.

"I am also playing the game with my sister right now," he said when he heard her surprised noise.

"Wait... I don't mean to be disrespectful, but you can play the game, Young Master? Even in your condition?" Wang Xiuying said with a dazed look.

"Yes. Although I don't know how it works, I can play the game perfectly fine, and I am even perfectly healthy while inside the game, so I can use my limbs and see with my eyes." Yuan said.

Both Doctor Wang and Wang Xiuying stared at him with gawking expressions on their faces.

"N-Now that you mention it... I recall seeing on the news that mentioned something like that— how even blind people can play the game and somehow use their sights in the game." Wang Xiuying spoke in a dazed voice afterward.

"W-Wait a minute! Does this mean I can watch you play the instrument again inside the game?! Let's play together, Young Master~!" Wang Xiuying said to him in a cheerful voice.

"I will be participating in the Dragon Essence Temple's disciple examination in a few days. If you want, we can meet there," Yuan said.

"Oh, I am already a disciple of another Sect— one that focuses on medicine and alchemy," Wang Xiuying sighed. "However, I'll definitely try to meet with you one day."

"What is your Sect called? If I am ever around the place, I can try to find you," Yuan said.

"It's called 'Pill Academy', located in the Northern Continent," she said.

"Northern Continent? That's quite far away since I am in the Eastern Continent," Yuan said.

"Oh... then it might be a while before we can play with each other..." Wang Xiuying sighed in a regretful voice.

However, Yu Rou was trying her hardest to not smile at her misfortune.

'Who knows what she might try to do to my brother when I am not there...' she sighed inwardly.

"Anyway, is there anything else you need from us, Doctor Wang?" Yu Rou asked him a moment later, as she wanted to return to playing Cultivation Online with Yuan.

"No, I just wanted to see if there were any changes to the Young Master's body after that incident. Since we have done the x-ray and have the results, there is nothing else I need from you two."

"Then we'll go home now. Thank you again, Doctor Wang, for taking the time to do this." Yu Rou said.

"Haha... Don't even mention it. Not only am I close with your parents but I am also a fan of the Young Lady and the Young Master." Doctor Wang laughed out loud.

"I'll walk them outside," Wang Xiuying said as she followed Yu Rou and Yuan outside to their limousine.

"I'll see you later, Young Master! I hope we get to play with each other soon!" Wang Xiuying waved at them as they entered the car.

"Yes, I hope so too," Yuan said to her.

Once the limousine drove off, Wang Xiuying returned to Doctor Wang's side.

"It's been a long time since I last saw the Young Master so energetic. We have never spoken to each other so much before. I bet it's all because of Cultivation Online, where he's able to live as a healthy young man again." Wang Xiuying said to Doctor Wang.

However, Doctor Wang didn't respond to her, and he was silently staring at Yuan's x-ray results.

"What's the matter, grandpa? Is there something wrong with the results?" Wang Xiuying asked him after noticing this.

"No, it's just that the Young Master's situation is extremely weird, to the point where it's not an exaggeration to call it a phenomenon..." Doctor Wang said in a profound voice, and he continued, "Looks like I will have to dig up and read some more ancient medical records. Perhaps I'll learn something new there."

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Chapter 83 - Silver Ape Cave

After returning to their home, Yu Rou and Yuan quickly dived into the world of cultivation known as Cultivation Online.

"Welcome back, Brother Yuan," Xiao Hua said to him after sensing that his presence had returned to the world.

"Hello, Xiao Hua." Yuan greeted her.

"What are we going to do today? Do you still want to continue practicing Wind Blade?" Yuan asked Yu Rou afterward.

"Yes, but I don't want to slow down your progress with my boring training," she sighed.

"What are you saying? It's called training for a reason. If you don't train, you won't get better," Yuan said to her. "Although it might be time-consuming, you'll have to do it eventually."

"I guess so..." Yu Rou nodded.

And since they last logged off while they were still in the wilderness, they didn't need to do any traveling and were able to continue hunting monsters instantly.

A few hours later...

"Congratulations, Yu Rou. You can finally slay the monsters without making a mess," Yuan said to her as he looked at the cleanly separated monster corpse with a smile on his face.

"Yes! And my mastery level for it increased by 1!" Yu Rou said with an excited expression on her face.

"And now that I am pretty confident in my own control of the skill, we can do something harder! Of course, it probably won't be a challenge for you no matter what we do at my level, though..."

"Something more difficult, huh? What do you have in mind?" Yuan asked her.

"A dungeon!" she quickly said. "There are multiple strong monsters in dungeons, and if we can find one that has never been discovered before, there's a high chance we might obtain valuable treasures!"

"A dungeon? Where do we find those?" Yuan asked her.

"Well, there are many known dungeons around this place, but they have already been searched by the other players so we won't find any treasures inside." Yu Rou said.

"Hmmm... What do you think, Xiao Hua? Do you know of any dungeons around here? Something like the Demonic Spider's Silent Cave." Yuan decided to ask her, who seemingly knew everything.

"Demonic Spider's Silent Cave... Do you mean Beast Nests? It's where wild beasts gather and make their home, and there are usually treasures inside because beasts instinctively pick up anything that has Qi." Xiao Hua asked him.

"Yes! That's exactly it! Do you know where we can find one?" Yu Rou asked her.

"Xiao Hua should be able to find some with her Divine Sense..."

Xiao Hua then closed her eyes, and a profound feeling expanded from her small body a moment later, sweeping many miles in an instant.

'Wow... What a powerful Divine Sense. I wonder how it feels to see so many things and so far at once... It's probably like having eyes in the sky.'

Yuan watched with slight envy, wondering how long it'll take before he can start doing the same thing.

'If I can also Divine Sense in the real world, that would be great, too.' Yuan sighed inwardly.

About a minute later, Xiao Hua opened her eyes again and said, "There is a Beast Nest a few kilometers from here, and there are about 30 beasts inside between the second level and sixth level Spirit Apprentice realm."

"Sixth level Spirit Apprentice... Do you think you can handle those, brother? I will take care of the ones below the fourth level." Yu Rou asked him.

"Of course," Yuan nodded.

"As for Xiao Hua... You can just stay behind us until we need you since it won't be challenging at all if someone as overpowered as you also fought the monsters alongside us." Yu Rou said to her.

"Well, although brother is also quite overpowered, at least he can't snap the monsters out of existence with his cultivation base..." Yu Rou then added.

"Okay," Xiao Hua nodded. She wouldn't do anything unless Yuan asked her to either way.

"Then let's go to this Beast Nest!"

Xiao Hua then led them to the location.

Many minutes later, once they reached the area, a notification popped up for both Yuan and Yu Rou.

«You have discovered 'Silver Ape Cave'»

"Silver Ape Cave... I don't recall seeing this name on the forums so we should be the first ones to have discovered this dungeon," Yu Rou said.

"That's good. Then let's clear this place up real quick—"

However, before Yuan could even take a step towards the dark cave, Yu Rou grabbed his arm and said, "Wait a second, brother! Have you forgotten? If we clear this dungeon together, our names will be announced to the entire world!"

"Oh, right... That would be disastrous for us. I don't want you getting caught up in my mess, after all." Yuan nodded.

If people see that Player Yuan has a teammate, the other players would also begin looking out for Yu Rou to find him, something he did not wish to see.

"Then what should we do?" Yuan asked her.

"How about this? Brother will go inside first and clear out the stronger monsters and then come back outside, then I will go inside and clean out the rest of the weaker monsters," Yu Rou suggested.

"That doesn't sound too bad, but I still don't want to leave you alone inside... Although they may be weak, accidents might happen," Yuan said to her, being extremely cautious when it came to Yu Rou's safety.

"Then why don't Xiao Hua come with me? Since she's an NPC, she won't appear on the announcements," Yu Rou said after a moment of pondering.

"Oh... Now that you mention it, that's true!" Yuan nodded. "Okay, let's do that."

A few moments later, Yuan retrieved his Starry Abyss and went inside the dark cave.

However, once he was inside, the entire place was well lit, almost like there were lamps inside.

Once he reached the end of the cave, there was a spacious area that resembled the Demonic Spider's Silent Cave boss area. However, in the middle of this spacious area were a dozen apes with silver fur and a massive glowing tree. This tree nearly reached the ceiling of the cave which was over 30 meters in height, and most of the Silver Apes were deep asleep

around this gigantic tree with a few of them playing on the thick tree branches.

After taking a minute to analyze the situation and the Silver Apes, he counted 6 Silver Apes at the sixth level Spirit Apprentice and 8 of them at the fifth level. The rest of them were between the second level and fourth level Spirit Apprentice realm.

Once he found his targets, Yuan casually approached the glowing tree.

"Hooo! Hooo! Hooo!"

"Ooo! Oooo! Oooo!"

When the Silver Apes playing on the tree noticed Yuan's presence, they began screaming to alert those that were asleep, immediately waking them up.

"Ooo! Ooo! Aaaah!"

"Hooo! Hooo! Ahhh!"

Very quickly, 36 screaming Silver Apes surrounded Yuan, who stood there with a calm expression on his face, seemingly unfazed by the situation.

A few moments later, some of the more powerful Silver Apes suddenly jumped at Yuan with their sharp claws spread wide open.

Seeing this, Yuan skillfully maneuvered the black dagger in his hands.

"Thousand Knife Techniques!"

The black dagger flickered, and multiple black arcs of lights appeared around him.

A second later, the Silver Apes that rushed at Yuan fell to the ground without any signs of life from their eyes or bodies.

When the other Silver Apes saw this, they began panicking. However, they did not run away.

After killing a few of the Silver Apes, Yuan began his own assault, specifically aiming for the Silver Apes with a higher cultivation base.

A few minutes later, all of the Silver Apes above the fourth level Spirit Apprentice were slain, leaving only the weaker ones.

"..."

After witnessing their strongest members being slain by Yuan without any efforts, the Silver Apes no longer dared to surround him and even began backing up to the massive tree.

Yuan approached the tree, but he did not attack the Silver Apes, puzzling them.

After looking around the tree and making sure there was nothing that Yu Rou couldn't handle, Yuan turned around and left the scene, dumbfounding the Silver Apes.

"Brother! Are you okay?" Yu Rou asked him after Yuan left the cave faster than she'd anticipated.

"Yes, and I have dealt with all of the Silver Apes above the fourth level Spirit Apprentice realm. Though, I do feel a bit sinful after storming in there and killing them when they were minding their own business..." Yuan sighed.

"You shouldn't feel pity for beasts, Brother Yuan. Although they may seem peaceful at glance, Silver Apes are vicious creatures that attack people in groups once they are hungry, and countless merchants and travelers have fallen to Silver Apes," Xiao Hua said to him.

"Is that so..." Yuan nodded.

"Anyway, it's my turn to have some fun!" Yu Rou said as she retrieved her Spirit Weaver.

"Be careful in there, Yu Rou. Although Xiao Hua is with you, don't get too ahead of yourself, as there are still over a dozen Silver Apes inside, and half of them are at the third level and above." Yuan said to her.

He then turned to look at Xiao Hua and said to her, "And Xiao Hua, make sure you protect my sister properly! Although she won't really die, it might affect her cultivation, and I cannot imagine seeing my sister's corpse even if it's just a game."

"Don't worry, Brother Yuan. Xiao Hua will protect your sister at all costs!" Xiao Hua nodded with a serious expression on her face.

Yuan nodded, and Yu Rou entered the Silver Ape Cave with Xiao Hua by her side a moment later.

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Chapter 84 - Spirit Frui

"Wow... So these are Silver Apes? And what's the massive glowing tree in the middle?" Yu Rou mumbled in a low voice after seeing the Silver Apes.

However, unlike previously, they were not sleeping around the tree. Instead, they were—

"A-Are they... Are they eating each other?" Yu Rou covered her mouth in shock after realizing that the Silver Apes were consuming the Silver Apes that had been slain by Yuan.

"That's their nature— they eat anything as long as they're hungry," Xiao Hua said.

"As for the glowing tree, that's a Spirit Tree. It can grow Spirit Fruits that benefit one's cultivation base. However, it takes many decades to grow even one, and the Silver Apes has already eaten all of them."

"What a pity..." Yu Rou sighed.

"Anyway, let's clear this Beast Nest. Xiao Hua, don't do anything yet. Although you may not be a player, you're still Brother Tian's servant, so your contribution might still be counted toward my brother's contribution, and his name will show up on the announcements."

Xiao Hua silently nodded at Yu Rou's words.

Yu Rou locked her eyes on the large group of Silver Apes gathered in a circle while consuming the dead Silver Apes.

After taking a deep breath, she swung the Spirit Weaver.

"Wind Blade!"

An arc of powerful wind flew towards the Silver Apes horizontally, and before the Silver Apes could even react, the Wind Blade had sliced a dozen Silver Apes in halves.

"Oooo! Aaaah! Ooo!"

Alerted, the Silver Apes immediately dropped their food and rushed at Yu Rou.

However, when they noticed the immense aura emitted by Xiao Hua, they immediately stopped in their tracks and stood there as though they were stone statues.

"What the?"

Although Yu Rou was dumbfounded by the situation, she didn't dare to stop and continue to throw Wind Blades at the Silver Apes.

Whoosh! Whoosh! Whoosh!

The Silver Apes dropped one at a time right in front of each other, yet none of them dared to move, almost as though they were rooted from fear.

A few minutes later, all of the Silver Apes were slain by Yu Rou, and an announcement appeared for the world to see.

«Congratulations! Player Yu Rou has become the first player to have cleared Silver Ape Cave!»

When Yuan saw the announcement in the sky, a relieved smile appeared on his face.

Once Yu Rou came back outside, Yuan praised her, "Wow, that was faster than I'd anticipated. Good job, Yu Rou."

However, Yu Rou did not celebrate and merely sighed in a dejected voice, "Something was wrong with those Silver Apes. It seemed like they were

going to attack me at first, but they suddenly stopped moving and allowed me to kill them without any effort. It was ridiculous and not fun at all!"

"Uh..." Yuan was speechless and did not know how to respond to her complaints, as he only cared about whether she was hurt or not.

"Anyway, you managed to clear the dungeon and received an announcement. This makes you an Ancestor, right?" Yuan asked her.

"While that is the case, since it's only a dungeon clear, my title isn't worth as much as your Skill and Servant category 'firsts'." Yu Rou said.

"Hmm... Then do you want to look for a few more dungeons to clear?" Yuan asked her a moment later.

"No, it's fine."

"Then what would you like to do now?"

"I would like to go on an epic journey that might take days, even weeks to complete, but I don't have the time for that now, so I want to spend my remaining time looking for a servant." Yu Rou said.

"A servant, huh? What do you think, Xiao Hua? Any way we can help my sister tame a beast?" Yuan asked her.

Xiao Hua nodded and said, "It's very easy to tame beasts. You just need to feed it some food and if it likes you, you can try to tame it."

"Huh? It's that easy?" Yu Rou looked at her with wide eyes.

Xiao Hua nodded again and said, "There are also techniques that allow you to tame and control beasts."

"Let's try the feeding method first. What kind of food should we be feeding them?" Yu Rou asked.

"It depends on what kind of beast you're trying to tame, but most of them like food that contains spiritual energy, especially Spirit Fruits. You are

almost guaranteed to tame most beasts with a Spirit Fruit," Xiao Hua said.

"Spirit Fruits, huh? It's such a pity that the Silver Apes had taken all of them." Yu Rou sighed.

"You can buy Spirit Fruits in the market, they are worth about 500,000 gold coins each."

"500,000 gold coins!" Yu Rou exclaimed. "That's a lot of money, but you can afford them without much trouble, right, brother?"

Yuan immediately began sweating after hearing her words, and he said a moment later, "I only have around 200,000 gold coins left."

"Huh? How's that possible? You're still number one on the Wealth Leaderboards! Surely, you have much more than 200,000 gold coins!" Yu Rou said.

"Well... most of that wealth is actually in Xiao Hua's possession," Yuan said.

Yu Rou then looked at Xiao Hua and said, "But that wealth is still brother's right?"

Xiao Hua nodded and said, "Xiao Hua is only holding it for Brother Yuan."

"Then what's the problem?" Yu Rou continued to ask.

"I didn't want to rely too much on Xiao Hua and wanted to earn my own money, so I would rather not use the money we'd earned from selling her treasure unless it's an emergency." Yuan explained to her.

"Oh, I see... Then I'll ask her." Yu Rou said, and she continued, "Xiao Hua, can I borrow 500,000 gold coins from you? I'll pay you back in the future. I also can't keep on relying on my brother forever."

Xiao Hua nodded her small head and retrieved 500,000 gold coins before handing it to Yu Rou without blinking an eye. In the eyes of a Cultivator at her level, 500,000 gold coins is a neglectable amount of wealth.

"Are you sure, Yu Rou? It's only 500,000 gold coins... You don't have to pay us back." Yuan said to her.

"I borrowed it from Xiao Hua, not you, brother, and I am not shameless enough to accept money without paying it back. And like I'd said, I don't want to be too reliant on you. If you can't accept that money from Xiao Hua, then you should know how I feel."

Hearing her words, Yuan nodded.

"Anyway, where can we buy a Spirit Fruit?" Yu Rou asked.

"Spirit Fruits are pretty rare, so only luxurious stores would have them," Xiao Hua said, and she continued, "There's a very popular place in Phoenix City named 'Golden Phoenix Bazaar', and you can find most rare and valuable treasures there."

"Great! Where is this place?" Yu Rou asked.

"Approximately 5,000 miles away. If we leave now, we should arrive there by tomorrow morning." Xiao Hua said.

"Tomorrow morning, huh? What do you think, Yu Rou? It won't be my first time playing throughout the whole night," Yuan said to her.

"Let's do it. Since I only have one more day before I have to return to school, I would like to play with you for as long as possible." Yu Rou nodded.

After retrieving his flying sword, Yuan picked up Yu Rou and jumped onto the sword before Xiao Hua flew towards the sky with them.

"Although it's going to take some time, I cannot wait to be able to use the flying sword by myself," Yu Rou said.

"Me too." Yuan nodded.

After flying for some time, they descended to take a quick break. After flying for a few more hours, the siblings logged off temporarily for dinner.

Once they logged back into the game, they returned to their journey, and Yu Rou would fall asleep in Yuan's arms shortly later.

Many hours later, by the time Yu Rou woke up, they had already traveled over 5,000 miles.

"Good morning, Yu Rou. We should be there within an hour," Yuan said to her.

"Brother...? Oh no! I accidentally fell asleep since flying felt so good!" Yu Rou exclaimed. "I'm sorry, brother..."

"Why are you apologizing?" Yuan shook his head.

"Even though you are doing this for me, I fell asleep and left you alone..." she sighed.

"It's fine. Anyway, look over there—I can see a phoenix." Yuan suddenly said to her.

"What?! A phoenix?!" Yu Rou immediately turned to look at where he was looking to see a large bird in the sky.

However, once they got closer to it, they realized that the phoenix was actually an enormous phoenix kite that was being flown from the city.

"A kite?" Yu Rou mumbled in a low and surprised voice, as this is her first time seeing such a massive kite.

"Rumors have it there is a living phoenix currently living in the city, and that kite is used to honor the phoenix," Xiao Hua said.

"Wait a second... A real phoenix living in the city? Surely, that must be fake, right? After all, who would be able to miss the majesty sight of a phoenix?" Yu Rou said.

"Magic beasts like phoenixes are considered as Divine Beasts, and they have the capability to take on a human form once they reach a certain

cultivation base, so it's not impossible that a phoenix could be living in the city disguised as a human," Xiao Hua explained.

"If there's really a phoenix, I'd like to meet one..." Yu Rou sighed as they descended a few miles from the city.

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Chapter 85 - Golden Phoenix Bazaar

«You have discovered Phoenix City»

When Yuan and the others approached the city, they immediately noticed the massive line stretching for at least a mile long from the city entrance.

"What in heaven's name? Why is the queue so long?" Yuan stared at the line with wide eyes.

"It's only natural this place is so busy. Phoenix City is one of the most popular areas within the Eastern Continent due to its rich environment and abundance of treasures, so powerful Cultivators and rich merchants from all over the world come here to do business," Xiao Hua explained to him.

"Anyway, let's get in line first. Over a dozen people had entered the line by the time you finished speaking!" Yuan said as he walked to the back of the line.

After standing in line for half an hour, it was finally their turn to enter the city.

"Place your hands on this ball," said one of the guards once Yuan approached them.

Yuan placed his hands on the crystal ball, and once the guards confirmed that he was not a criminal, they said, "Entrance fee for Phoenix City is one gold coin."

"The three of us are together," Yuan said as he handed them 3 pieces of gold coins.

"Here are your guest permits. Due to the immense population and not wanting to overpopulate the city, you are only allowed to stay in Phoenix City for three days. If you are caught past your date, you'll be fined 100,000 gold coins. If you wish to stay longer, you must visit the Administration Hall, and you can extend your time for a price."

"I understand, " Yuan had to agree to such rules before they were finally allowed inside.

"Wow, this place is far more popular than I'd thought if they need to make such rules fearing for overpopulation..." Yuan said once they were inside.

"Most popular cities that focus on business are like this," Xiao Hua said.

"Well, three days is more than enough, as we'll be leaving immediately after we obtain a Spirit Fruit. Anyway, where do we go now?" Yuan asked her.

However, Xiao Hua shook her head and said, "Xiao Hua has never been here before— she has only heard of the Golden Phoenix Bazaar being here."

"Then I guess we'll have to ask around," Yuan said.

After spending a few minutes speaking to the pedestrians, Yuan got a good idea of the direction and began making his way towards the Golden Phoenix Bazaar with the other two girls.

"This place is really meant for business only. No matter where we go, the streets are filled with nothing but shops." Yu Rou said as they walked, enjoying the scenery. "Do people even live in this city? Because I haven't seen any houses yet."

"Only the wealthiest of people would live in a place like Phoenix City, and they are all within the center of the city. Do you see those tall buildings in the distance? They are houses." Xiao Hua said as she pointed in that direction.

"What?! Those pagodas are actually homes?! That's like living in Cultivators' Haven, which has 21 floors!" Yu Rou exclaimed.

After walking for many minutes, they reached this extremely wide street with a beautiful 'Golden Phoenix Bazaar' kite flying in the sky.

"Wow, so this is the Golden Phoenix Bazaar... But why does it appear so empty compared to the other streets?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

Xiao Hua shrugged.

"I guess it doesn't really matter why there are so few people here. Anyway, we should just look at every store until we find one that's selling Spirit Fruits, right?" Yuan said.

"Un." They nodded.

However, right as Yuan prepared to enter the street, they were immediately stopped by the guards standing not too far away.

"Wait a second. Do you have permission to enter this area?" The guards asked them.

"Permission? We need permission to enter the Golden Phoenix Bazaar?" Yuan asked them with a surprised look, as this is his first time hearing this.

"Naturally. The Golden Phoenix Bazaar is not your ordinary place where one can enter normally, and only those with a permit are allowed to do business here."

"Then where do we get a permit? I'd like to buy something in there." Yuan asked them.

"This must be your first time here. Even getting the permit to enter this place is not that simple. First and foremost, you must donate a generous amount of money to the city lord before you can even be considered for the permit." The guard said to him.

"Money...?" Yuan immediately began sweating. "How much are we talking about?"

"Most people donate at least 10,000,000 gold coins," said the guard.

"10,000,000 gold coins?!" Yuan's jaw dropped to the ground.

If one must pay 10,000,000 to use the Golden Phoenix Bazaar, they might as well go somewhere else! At least they would still have 10,000,000 gold coins to spend by doing so!

"What's so special about the Golden Phoenix Bazaar, anyway? Requiring 10,000,000 coins for a permit to shop at a place is simply outrageous if you ask me. Nobody in their right mind would pay so much money for that." Yu Rou shook her head, unable to comprehend the reason behind this system.

"That's where you're wrong, young lady. Although it may be expensive, it is very well worth it, as the people you can find in this place are mostly renowned experts with immense backing or status in this world, and most people come here mainly to make connections with these individuals—shopping is only secondary." The guard explained to them the true purpose of the Golden Phoenix Bazaar.

"I see... that makes more sense..." Yu Rou nodded.

"What about the Spirit Fruit? Since we cannot enter this place without spending an extra 10,000,000 gold coins, we'll have to look elsewhere for them," Yuan sighed.

"Spirit Fruits? If you are looking for Spirit Fruits, then you can only find them inside the Golden Phoenix Bazaar," one of the guards said after hearing Yuan's words.

"How convenient..." Yuan sighed again.

"If you really want to enter the Golden Phoenix Bazaar, there are methods that don't require payments or permits, though." One of the guards suddenly said.

"What are those methods?" Yuan immediately asked.

"It's quite simple, actually."

The guards exchanged glances with each other before speaking—

"You just need a recommendation from a Spirit Grandmaster Cultivator!"

"If you reach the Spirit Grandmaster realm, you will be allowed to enter the Golden Phoenix Bazaar without any limitations!"

"Hahaha!"

The guards burst out laughing afterward, thinking that it was more realistic to pay 10,000,000 gold coins than to find someone at the Spirit Grandmaster realm.

"Spirit Grandmaster? Why didn't you say so? We have one right here." Yuan said with a relieved smile on his face.

"What did you just say? That there's a Spirit Grandmaster amongst you? Who? You? Hahaha!" The guards didn't take Yuan seriously and began laughing even louder.

"Well, she's not exactly a Spirit Grandmaster— she's a Spirit King," Yuan said as he pointed at Xiao Hua.

"Spirit King?! HAHAAHAHAHA!" The guards laughed so hard after hearing his words that they'd begun rolling on the floor dying from laughter.

Yuan looked at the guards with a dumbfounded expression on his face. Why are they laughing so hard? What's so funny?

"If... If this little girl is a Cultivator with a Spirit Grandmaster cultivation base, much less Spirit King, I will run an entire lap around the Golden Phoenix Bazaar while naked!" One of the guards suddenly said.

"Only the Golden Phoenix Bazaar? I am willing to run around the entire city naked if she's really a Spirit King! Hahaha!"

"..."

Yu Rou and Yuan looked at each other with raised eyebrows.

"What are you two laughing at while on duty? I have been in a bad mood lately so I can use a few laughs! Go ahead, tell me what's so funny!"

A clear but irritated feminine voice suddenly resounded, and when the guards heard this female's voice, they immediately stopped laughing and turned around with fearful expressions on her faces, looking as though they were staring at death.

Yuan and Yu Rou also turned to look at the person who'd just spoken, and a very beautiful woman in her late twenties wearing red robes with a golden phoenix pattern could be seen walking in their direction.

"M-Madam Feng!" The guards immediately kowtowed on the ground with their back soaked in cold sweats. "W-We were wrong for laughing while on duty! Please have mercy!"

However, the woman being addressed as Madam Feng coldly snorted, "Did you not hear me? I want to know what's so funny that it made you laugh like maniacs!"

"W-Well... it's like this..."

The guards proceeded to explain the situation to Madam Feng.

A few moments later, Madam Feng turned her focus from the guards to Yuan and the two girls beside him.

"So you think it's funny to joke about being a Spirit King, huh?" Madam Feng narrowed her eyes at them and suddenly—

Boom!

The cultivation base of a Spirit Grandmaster suddenly erupted from Madam Feng's body, filling the area with a suffocating pressure, causing Yuan and Yu Rou to begin choking as though they were having trouble breathing.

"Do you still think it's funny to—"

However, before Madam Feng could even finish her sentence, Xiao Hua shouted in a cute but angry voice, "How dare you hurt Brother Yuan!"

Boom!

An immense pressure that far exceeded Madam Feng's pressure suddenly appeared to cancel out Madam Feng's pressure, before forcing Madam Feng onto her knees.

"T-This is?!" Madam Feng lifted her head with much effort to look at Xiao Hua, her gaze filled with shock and fear.

"A Spirit King!"

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Chapter 86 - Madam Feng

'A real Spirit King! She's a real Spirit King! But how is that possible?! How can a Spirit King possibly remain in the Lower Heavens?!' Madam Feng cried inwardly after realizing her mistake that could potentially end her life.

"Please have mercy, Senior Spirit King! This junior had eyes but still failed to recognize your mighty presence!" Madam Feng then kowtowed on the floor with her smooth forehead kissing the solid floor.

However, Xiao Hua did not budge and continued to release her spiritual energy.

"What's going on here?! Which expert is emitting this powerful presence?!"

"This expert definitely surpasses the Spirit Grandmaster realm! The Spirit Lord realm? No! It's even higher! This presence belongs to a Spirit King!"

The other experts located within the Golden Phoenix Bazaar were greatly shocked when they sensed Xiao Hua's immense presence that appeared out of thin air. However, they were too scared to even peek their heads out the windows to see the situation, much less show themselves, and unless directly told to, they would rather not stick their noses where it doesn't belong, especially when a Spirit King was involved.

After all, a single mistake could mean the end of their business and even their life! That's how much power a Spirit King holds in this Lower Heavens where the peak experts are only at the Spirit Grandmaster realm!

Meanwhile, at the entrance of the Golden Phoenix Bazaar, Madam Feng remained kowtowing on the floor, not even daring to lift her head.

"Xiao Hua, it's okay now. We're not hurt," Yuan said to her a moment later.

"Un." Xiao Hua nodded her head and immediately retrieved her powerful aura, allowing Madam Feng to breathe again.

"Are you okay?" Yuan approached Madam Feng before extending his hand out to her.

"T-Thank you..." Fearing that Xiao Hua might get angry at her again if she doesn't accept his hands, Madam Feng grabbed Yuan's hands and allowed him to pull her to her feet.

"Anyway, I will apologize again for getting ahead of myself and causing trouble for you, and I never intended on harming you."

Madam Feng lowered her head and bowed to them in an apologetic manner after she was standing again.

"It was only a misunderstanding, you don't have to take it to the heart," Yuan said with a calm smile on his face.

"Anyway, since you have confirmed that Xiao Hua is indeed at the Spirit King level, we should be able to shop in the Golden Phoenix Bazaar, right?" Yuan then asked her.

"Y-Yes..." Madam Feng quickly nodded her head. Nobody would dare to stop them even if they wanted to live in the Golden Phoenix Bazaar.

And she continued, "If you don't mind, I can help you with whatever you're looking for. I am the owner of the Phoenix Heaven in the Golden Phoenix Bazaar, one of the most renowned stores in the city. No matter what kind of treasure you're looking for, we will have it. If we don't, we'll know where you can find it."

"That'd be great!" Yuan said, and he continued, "We're looking to buy a Spirit Fruit."

"Spirit Fruit...?" Madam Feng looked at him with a dazed face, seemingly speechless.

Yuan immediately began feeling nervous after seeing Madam Feng's reaction, worried that it might not be available because of its rarity.

However, Madam Feng was thinking the complete opposite, as Spirit Fruits are pretty worthless in the Golden Phoenix Bazaar, where the treasures are usually worth 100 times more than Spirit Fruits.

"If it's only Spirit Fruits, I can offer some to you for free..." Madam Feng said to him a moment later.

"Really? Isn't it very expensive, though?" Yuan looked at her with wide eyes.

"Yes, it's my way of saying sorry for the trouble I've caused you three today." Madam Feng said. "And if I have to be honest, Spirit Fruits aren't that valuable in my eyes, as my shop sells things that are worth way more."

"Since you don't mind, I won't be humble," Yuan nodded his head.

"Please, follow me." Madam Feng said as she turned around and began walking away.

"Isn't this great, Yu Rou? We don't have to spend any money on the Spirit Fruit now," Yuan said to her as they followed Madam Feng.

"Un," she nodded.

A few minutes later, they entered this luxurious building that was somewhere in the middle of the Golden Phoenix Bazaar.

"Welcome back, Madam Feng. Welcome to the Phoenix Heaven, esteemed guests." The workers inside greeted them the moment they entered the building.

Madam Feng nodded her head before speaking to one of the workers there, "Bring me three Spirit Fruits and wrap them up nicely; it's for these esteemed guests."

"As you wish, Madam Feng." The worker bowed before walking away.

"Three Spirit Fruit? We only planned on buying one," Yuan said to her afterward.

"Don't worry about it, one or three— it doesn't make a difference to me," Madam Feng said to him with a smile, and then she suggested, "Anyway, it might take some time for them to wrap up the Spirit Fruits. Why don't I show you around the store while we are waiting?"

Hearing her words, Yuan nodded, and they proceeded to follow Madam Feng around the first floor of the building.

"How much are the treasures here usually worth? I don't see any price tags." Yuan suddenly asked her out of curiosity.

"The first floor mostly contains treasures worth between 10 million gold coins and 100 million gold coins," Madam Feng quickly responded to him.

"100 million gold coins...?" Yuan looked at her with a dazed face.

There appeared to be around six floors in this building, and if the first floor already contained treasures that are worth tens of millions of gold coins then he cannot imagine what kind of treasure they have on the top floors.

"What is this?" Yuan suddenly stopped in front of a display case that had a single red leaf inside, wondering how this is even a treasure.

"That's a Blood Leaf from the Devil's Forest— it's a rare treasure that requires 500 years to naturally grow," Madam Feng explained to him. "It's usually used in strengthening pills."

"Is that so..." Yuan mumbled in a low voice.

A few minutes later, they finished seeing all of the treasures on the first floor.

"Do you wish to see the other floors?" Madam Feng asked him afterward after noticing how much they were enjoying the tour, especially Yuan, whose eyes were essentially glowing with excitement.

"If you don't mind," Yuan said.

"Haha... Why would I?" Madam Feng laughed in a slightly awkward voice.

While she normally wouldn't allow strangers to the higher floors, there was simply nothing she could do when there was a Spirit King amongst them. Even if Yuan wanted to rob the entire building, Madam Feng could only stand there with a smile on her face while they rob the store.

However, since Yuan did not appear to be that kind of person, even feeling kind of pleasant to be around, Madam Feng wasn't too worried about showing them the treasures, or else she wouldn't even have suggested it in the first place.

Madam Feng brought Yuan and the others to the second floor a few moments later, but there appeared to be fewer display cases on the second floor compared to the first floor.

"How much are the treasures on this floor?" Yuan couldn't help but ask.

"Around 100 million gold coins to 200 million," she said with a smile.

"200 million..." Yuan could feel himself sweating just from hearing the enormous amount of wealth.

Madam Feng then continued, "The treasures on the third and fourth floor are worth around 200 million to 700 million."

"On the fifth floor, the treasures are all worth over one billion gold coins, but since the amount is so high, we normally accept only Spirit Crystal from that point forth."

"As for the sixth floor... Most of the treasures there are priceless, so we only accept trades with a similar value for it."

After seeing every treasure on the second floor, they continued onto the third floor.

"This is a Divine-grade sword?" Yuan gazed at the beautiful and sharp sword in the display case with admiration in his eyes.

"That sword is called 'Thousand Lords', and although it is only of low-quality, it is immensely powerful—to the point where even a Mortal would be able to cleave an entire mountain in half if they could wield it."

"Xiao Hua, at what cultivation level do I need to be in order to wield something like this?" Yuan decided to ask her.

"Brother Yuan should be able to wield Earth-grade treasures now, perhaps even low-quality Heaven-grade treasures. However, you'll need to reach Spirit Grandmaster before you can even consider wielding a Divine-grade treasure."

"Spirit Grandmaster... That's quite far away..." Yuan sighed.

After spending a few minutes on the third floor, right as they prepared to head onto the fourth floor, one of the workers there approached them with three luxurious-looking square boxes.

"Madam Feng, here are the Spirit Fruits you have requested."

Madam Feng accepted the Spirit Fruits before handing them to Yuan.

"Here you go, esteemed guests. It's not much, but please accept this small token from me."

"Thank you..." Yuan accepted the boxes with a humble expression on his face.

"Although you now have what you came for, do you still wish to see the other floors? I can see that you have a fascination for swords. Since that's the case, you'll definitely love what I have on the top floor." Madam Feng said to him afterward.

While she could just let Yuan leave now, she didn't want them to leave before she could create some sort of connection with them, especially with Xiao Hua, a Spirit King.

"Okay," Yuan immediately nodded, as he was also curious about the treasures on the higher floors.

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Chapter 87 - Empyrean Overlord

After putting away the Spirit Fruits into his spatial ring, Yuan and the others followed Madam Feng to the fourth floor, where even fewer display cases were available.

"What kind of pill is this?" Yu Rou suddenly asked after seeing the reddish pill in the display case, as she cannot imagine how a single pill could possibly cost hundreds of millions of gold coins.

"That's the Spirit Advancement Pill; it can boost the cultivation base of any Cultivator before the Spirit Master realm by an entire realm— so nine levels." Madam Feng explained to her.

"An entire realm?! So I can reach the Spirit Warrior realm right now if I swallowed it?" Yu Rou asked, her voice filled with shock.

"Correct. However, you can only consume one of these in your lifetime, so most people would consume it at the first level Spirit Warrior realm so they can become a Spirit Master instantly."

"Wow... How much would one of these costs?" Yuan asked afterward.

"650 million gold coins," Madam Feng responded with a smile on her face.

"650 million?!" Yuan's jaw dropped. It didn't take him much effort or money to reach the fifth level Spirit Warrior realm, so the ridiculous price seemed unjustified in his eyes.

However, to the majority of Cultivators in this world that require months and even years of effort for a single breakthrough, if they could potentially save many years of their life with a single pill, the Spirit Advancement Pill was worth every penny if they could afford it.

After walking a circle around the fourth floor, Madam Feng brought them onto the fifth floor, where only seven items were being sold.

"Everything in here is worth over 1 billion gold coins...? I wonder what you can do with that amount of money in this world..." Yu Rou mumbled.

"Although one billion gold coins may seem like a lot, it's actually not as much as you are thinking. An average sect will earn and spend tens of millions of gold coins a month, whilst the bigger ones spend hundreds of millions of gold coins every month." Madam Feng said.

"But that's for an entire sect with thousands of people, right? I cannot imagine someone spending so much money on a single individual," Yu Rou shook her head.

"If you are talented enough, people will be willing to spend as much resource as needed. You will be surprised by how much resources wealthy families spend on their most talented children." Madam Feng said with a smile on her face.

"Let's take this Golden Spirit Silk for example. This Golden Spirit Silk is a very important ingredient for an extremely rare and powerful pill that will permanently increase an individual's cultivation speed. If you have a very talented individual in your family and enough money, would you be willing to spend it on this person, who will surely become a great figure in the future and earn much more than what you'd spent? There's really not much difference between investing in business hoping for a good return and investing in an individual hoping to maximize their growth."

"Investing into a person's future, huh?" Yu Rou turned to look at Yuan, who was considered to be one of the most talented child prodigies in history, and how much their family had invested into him before he became a cripple.

"Do you know of a herb called the Seven Colored Herb? How much do you think one of those would cost?" Yuan suddenly asked her, who appeared very experienced in prices for treasures.

"The Seven Colored Herb? Now that's a treasure everyone with a store in the Golden Phoenix Bazaar would covet even though they probably won't try to sell it. If I had one right now, it would be placed on the sixth floor, as they are extremely rare and priceless."

"Priceless, huh..." Yuan nodded.

"..."

Seeing his reaction, Madam Feng narrowed her eyes at him, wondering if he had in his possession a Seven Colored Herb.

"Anyway, let's continue the tour." Madam Feng said a moment later, and they returned to looking at the display cases whilst Madam Feng explained to them the history and value for each of these treasures that are worth over a billion gold coins.

Sometime later, Madam Feng brought Yuan and the others onto the top floor in the building.

"There are only 3 items on this floor?" Yuan mumbled after seeing three thick display cases perfectly distanced from each other. However, unlike the previous transparent display cases, these display cases were completely black, resembling glasses that were tinted to the extreme.

"These display cases are protected by a powerful formation that can block even attacks from a Spirit Grandmaster such as myself," Madam Feng said to them.

Then she snapped her fingers, and one of the display cases suddenly became transparent again, allowing them to see the item inside.

"Is that... Is that a heart?" Yuan asked in a baffled voice after seeing the red pulsing object that resembled a beating heart.

"It's still beating, too!" Yu Rou exclaimed.

"Although it looks like this and closely resembles a heart, it is actually a Monster Core that once belonged to an extremely fearsome magical beast at

the Spirit Grandmaster realm," Madam Feng said.

"A monster core?! This beating thing?!" Yuan's jaw dropped, as this is his first time seeing such a unique-looking monster core. Although he can eat normal monster cores without batting an eye, he will definitely have trouble putting something this disgusting into his mouth.

"The Spirit Grandmaster demonic beast was a special existence that had demonic blood flowing in its veins, hence why its monster core looks this way." Madam Feng said.

"Demons? How do they differ from magical beasts?" Yuan asked.

"Demons are extremely powerful and fearsome monsters that resemble humans but are neither human nor beasts— they are bloodthirsty entities with unknown origins, so we do not know how they came into existence. However, we do know that they are extremely powerful and feared by most people," she explained.

"I see..." Yuan nodded.

"Well, you won't find any demons in the Lower Heavens, though, as they are usually too powerful to exist here." Madam Feng said a moment later.

"Let's move onto the next item. I have a feeling that you'll really like it."

After snapping her fingers, the second display case revealed itself.

"This is... a sword?" Yuan looked at the beautiful yet fierce-looking sword in the long display case with admiration, and his hands quickly became itchy, as he had this strong urge to hold the sword.

"This is not your ordinary treasure— it's a Soul Weapon," Madam Feng said with a smile on her face. "And it's called the Empyrean Overlord."

"A Soul Weapon?" Yuan became even more interested after hearing that.

"Hm? Don't you also have a Soul Weapon, brother?" Yu Rou suddenly recalled.

"Eh?" Madam Feng looked at Yuan with wide eyes filled with surprise.

"Y-You also have a Soul Weapon? If you don't mind, can I see it?" she asked him a moment later in a trembling voice.

"Sure." Yuan nodded and retrieved the Starry Abyss the next second.

"Amazing! This is my first time encountering another individual with a Soul Weapon!" Madam Feng exclaimed, and she continued, "If you don't mind me asking, where did you obtain this beauty?"

"It was given to me by some people I helped," he said in a calm voice.

"I-It was given to you...?" Madam Feng mumbled in a trembling voice with a dazed expression on her beautiful face, wondering what kind of person would give away a Soul Weapon just because they had been helped by him?

"What about you? Where did you obtain this sword?" Yuan then asked her.

"I found this baby inside the Legacy Tomb of some powerful Cultivator five hundred years ago," Madam Feng said with a nostalgic feeling around her.

"Legacy Tomb? What's that?" Yuan tilted his head.

"They are essentially a Cultivator's graveyard, Brother Yuan. When a powerful Cultivator is near death but they want to pass down their legacy, they will create these areas to challenge those who wish to attain their legacy, and whoever passes the challenges will obtain all of that Cultivator's wealth," Xiao Hua explained to him.

"I'm more interested in how long ago you found it... 500 years? Do Cultivators really live that long?" Yu Rou said to Madam Feng with a dazed look on her face, as she cannot even imagine living past 150, much less 500.

"Yes, most Cultivators at the Spirit Grandmaster realm can live up to 1,000 years," Madam Feng said to her.

"1,000 years? Then what about a Spirit King?" Yu Rou asked as she turned to look at Xiao Hua.

"..." Xiao Hua's eyebrows immediately twitched, as she understood Yu Rou's intent on asking such a question.

"I'm not really sure, but they should have a longevity of at least 10,000 years..." Madam Feng answered with an innocent face.

"10,000 years?!" Yu Rou's jaw dropped, and her curiosity regarding Xiao Hua's age intensified.

"Anyway, even though I managed to obtain this Soul Weapon, I cannot use it, as it won't recognize me as its owner no matter what I did." Madam Feng sighed afterward.

"It won't recognize you...?" Yuan mumbled with a profound expression on his face.

When Xiao Hua saw this, she turned to look at Madam Feng before asking her, "Since the Soul Weapon is on display in this store, you are willing to sell it, right?"

Hearing her question, Madam Feng immediately nodded, "T-That's correct! Though, I am mostly looking to trade it for something of similar value... if you don't mind..."

Madam Feng spoke in a reserved voice, as her fear for Xiao Hua still lingered within her heart.

Meanwhile, Yuan stared at Xiao Hua whose intentions were clear as day with a surprised face, clearly speechless.

Chapter 88 - Trading For The Soul Weapon

"Xiao Hua... don't tell me you are going to..." Yuan looked at her with his eyes wide open.

Xiao Hua nodded and said, "Brother Yuan looked like he wanted to hold the sword, and Xiao Hua believes that she should invest in Brother Yuan's future, as there's no doubt that he'll become a great figure in the future."

"While it's true that I wanted to try holding the sword, it is an exaggeration to say that I want it..." Yuan said with a perplexed expression on his face.

However, Yu Rou said with a smile on her face, "There's no need to be humble, brother. You may be able to fool others but you cannot fool me. I know you want that sword, and as Xiao Hua said, you are worth the investment."

"Yu Rou... you..." Yuan shook his head at his little sister who'd betrayed him. The only reason why he refused the Soul Weapon was because he feared the enormous price that Xiao Hua might have to pay in order to obtain it for him.

"Anyway, what do you want in exchange for the Soul Weapon? Are you looking for something in particular?" Xiao Hua returned to Madam Feng.

"Honestly, I have been hoping to exchange the Empyrean Overlord for another Soul Weapon—one that I can use. However, I have had the Empyrean Overlord for over 500 years now, and there have been countless individuals interested in it, but alas, I have not met another individual with a

Soul Weapon until today, and I doubt you would be willing to part with your current Soul Weapon." Madam Feng sighed.

"Weapons, huh? Although Xiao Hua does not have any Soul Weapon, she has plenty of treasures..." Xiao Hua then opened her spatial ring and began pulling out weapons one after another until the floor was littered with at least a dozen weapons, each emitting its own powerful aura.

"..."

Not just Madam Feng, but even Yu Rou and Yuan were staring at Xiao Hua with gawking expressions on their faces. Just how many treasures does she have?

"T-These are all..." Madam Feng's body trembled in excitement after feeling the auras coming from these treasures.

"They are all peak-quality Divine-grade treasures. Pick as many as you want for the Soul Weapon," Xiao Hua said with a calm expression on her face. Since she'd already planned on giving these weapons to Yuan in the future, it wouldn't make a difference if she traded them for another weapon that he'll be using.

"D-Divine-grade treasures..." Yu Rou's mouth salivated from the sight of so many endgame treasures.

A single one of these treasures would shake the entire world and its entire playerbase, yet there were over a dozen of them laying before her on the floor. If she'd posted this on the forums online, nobody would believe her even if they were beaten to death.

After a long moment of silence, Xiao Hua spoke, "You're not satisfied? If you cannot pick, Xiao Hua will exchange all of them for the Soul Weapon ____"

"W-Wait a moment, Senior..." Madam Feng suddenly said in a trembling voice, "I-I am just speechless. A single one of these treasures could easily fetch over 500 million gold coins... And you're willing to exchange a dozen

of them for the Soul Weapon...? That'll make me look like I am trying to take advantage of you!"

"Then what do you want for the Soul Weapon?" Xiao Hua asked her again, seemingly annoyed that she cannot make up her mind.

"Then if you don't mind, I will take these three Divine-grade treasures..." Madam Feng picked three of the Divine-grade weapons off the floor and showed them to Xiao Hua.

"Okay." Xiao Hua nodded her head without hesitation, as she wouldn't have minded even if Madam Feng wanted all of them since Soul Weapons are truly priceless.

Once Madam Feng accepted the Divine-grade weapons, Xiao Hua returned the rest into her spatial ring.

Meanwhile, Madam Feng retrieved the Empyrean Overlord from the display case and handed it to Yuan. "Thank you for doing business with Phoenix Heaven, esteemed guests."

"This is the Empyrean Overlord..." Yuan held the massive sword that was nearly his height with both of his hands, barely keeping it from falling due to its immense weight.

"T-This is much heavier than I'd expected..." Yuan exclaimed afterward.

"Well, it weighs over 1,000 jins, not to mention the Soul Weapon hasn't recognized you as its master yet. If you can control it, it should become as light as a feather." Madam Feng said.

And then she continued, "Oh, I forgot to ask you this, but have you been acknowledged by your other Soul Weapon?"

"Eh? Does that matter?" Yuan asked her.

"Un," she nodded and continued, "Most people can only contract one Soul Weapon at a time unless they have a strong soul. However, even if one has the capability to control two Soul Weapons at once, there's a high chance

that the Soul Weapons would reject each other, as most Soul Weapons do not like sharing their resources."

"Sharing their resources?" Yuan raised an eyebrow.

"Soul Weapons grow with their owners, but if you have two Soul Weapons, it's only logical that they will have to share that experience, slowing down their growth by half." Madam Feng explained to him.

"I had no idea it would be like that... and yes, I am already contracted with the Starry Abyss," Yuan said to her. "It would suck if I am unable to contract it because of the Starry Abyss since I like them both equally."

"Well... there's no harm in trying. If it doesn't work out, I don't mind giving you a refund," Madam Feng said.

"Don't worry, Brother Yuan. With your talents, you'll have no trouble controlling two Soul Weapons at once!" Xiao Hua said to him.

"That's right, brother. Don't underestimate yourself." Yu Rou patted his back for encouragement.

Yuan nodded and laid the sword on the floor. He then poked a hole in his finger with the Starry Abyss before squeezing a drop of his blood onto the sword.

The moment his blood touched the Empyrean Overlord, it immediately began trembling. However, it was not just the Empyrean Overlord that had a reaction to Yuan's blood, as Madam Feng suddenly felt a shiver going down her spine.

'This smell is...?' Madam Feng unconsciously raised her eyebrows after smelling an indescribable fragrance that had suddenly appeared in the room and instantly attracted her attention.

Meanwhile, the Empyrean Overlord on the floor suddenly began levitating off the floor.

"Oh?" Yuan became excited after seeing the Empyrean Overlord reacting the same way the Starry Abyss had when he contracted it.

The Starry Abyss in his grasp also suddenly began trembling, almost as though it was trying to communicate with the Empyrean Overlord.

After an entire minute had passed with both Soul Weapons trembling nonstop, they suddenly stopped moving.

Another moment later—

«Congratulations! The Empyrean Overlord has recognized you as its owner!»

«Empyrean Overlord»

«Level: 0»

«Rank: Soul Weapon»

«Growth Rate: Very Slow»

«Requirement: ???»

«Description: A mythical sword once wielded by the Sword Emperor. It can be as light as a feather or as heavy as a star»

"It worked! The contract worked! It recognized me as its Master!" Yuan shouted in excitement after seeing the notification.

"Congratulations, Brother Yuan." Xiao Hua said to him without much surprise on her face.

"See? There's nothing you cannot do, brother." Yu Rou said with a smile on her face.

However, as they were celebrating, Madam Feng suddenly moved and approached Yuan.

"What's wrong, Madam Feng?" Yuan asked her when she got extremely close to him.

"I'm sorry, but I cannot control myself right now..." Madam Feng spoke as she suddenly grabbed Yuan's hand that was still bleeding slightly and lifted it towards her own face.

"Aaaah..."

Madam Feng took a deep breath with an elated expression on her face before she opened her mouth and shoved Yuan's bleeding finger into her own mouth, shocking everybody there.

"M-Madam Feng?!" Yuan exclaimed, yet he couldn't remove his arm when he tried, as he was being tightly held by a Spirit Grandmaster, and he could feel Madam Feng sucking on his finger— or more precisely, his blood.

"W-What are you doing to my brother?!" Yu Rou also cried out loud, her eyes wide with shock.

However, almost as though she was in a trance, Madam Feng ignored everything around her and continued sucking on Yuan's finger with an enchanted expression on her face, looking like she was charmed by the taste of his blood.

"Get away from Brother Yuan!" Xiao Hua waved her sleeves with a frown on her small and round face, forcing Madam Feng off the terrified Yuan.

"Thank god my finger is still here!" Yuan sighed in relief after seeing that his finger, albeit wet with Madam Feng's saliva, was still intact.

After a long moment of awkward silence, Madam Feng finally snapped out of her daze, and when she realized what she'd just done, she immediately kowtowed on the floor with her face flushed with redness, "I-I-I am so sorry! I don't know what happened to me just now! Something about your blood had attracted me, and I unconsciously...! I swear I didn't do it on purpose!"

"My blood...?" Yuan looked at her wet finger with raised eyebrows. Why would his blood attract her? Unless Madam Feng turned out to be a vampire, there was no logical explanation behind her actions just now.

"Please! Believe me! I really don't know what happened just now!" Madam Feng continued to beg for forgiveness.

"It's fine... I was just a little surprised, that's all..." Yuan said with a smile on his face.

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Chapter 89 - Phoenix Blood

"Are you really okay, Brother Yuan?" Xiao Hua asked him in a worried voice.

"Yes, I am not hurt. She was just sucking my blood, that's all," Yuan nodded.

"Sucking your blood?" Yu Rou raised her eyebrows and looked at Madam Feng, who remained kneeling there with a guilty expression on her face.

"Anyway, let's forget about this and continue with the tour— there's still one item left, and I would very much like to see it," Yuan said a moment later.

"Right away, esteemed guest!" Madam Feng quickly stood up and snapped her fingers, causing the third and last display case to reveal the treasure inside.

Once the third treasure was revealed, both Yu Rou and Yuan raised their eyebrows.

"This is... a jade slip?" Yuan placed his head in front of the display case and narrowed his eyes, making sure he wasn't seeing things.

"This object has this indescribable feeling to it..." Yu Rou also looked at it with curiosity. "What is this thing?"

"The jade slip is just a container. The real treasure is inside, and inside the jade slip is a single drop of blood." Madam Feng responded.

"Blood?" They looked at her with raised eyebrows.

"Of course, it is not just any ordinary blood, as it once belonged to a legendary divine beast—the Vermilion Phoenix." Madam Feng spoke with a smile on her face.

"Vermilion Phoenix? So there is phoenix blood inside that jade slip?" Even Xiao Hua became interested after learning of its origins, as phoenixes are extremely rare divine beasts.

"That's right, and this is authentic phoenix blood." Madam Feng nodded.

"How can you tell it's real phoenix blood?" Yuan asked. "Is there some way to test it?"

"There is, but that requires one to consume the blood and test its effects, which is a complete waste since there's only a single drop. However, we know this is real phoenix blood without needing to test it because it was given to us by the Vermilion Phoenix herself." Madam Feng said to them.

"What? You have met the phoenix?" Yuan looked at her with wide eyes.

"No, I haven't. The phoenix blood had been passed down many generations, and it was my ancestors that obtained the phoenix blood from the Vermilion Phoenix." Madam Feng shook her head.

"Is that so? Then does this phoenix blood actually do anything besides being extremely rare?" Yu Rou asked her.

"Of course," Madam Feng quickly nodded. "Phoenix blood is a miracle treasure with many effects. A single drop can bring a half-dead man back to life! It can also heal any illness and injuries, and it could even regrow your limbs. Furthermore, if you consume phoenix blood, your longevity will increase significantly! Depending on the quality of the blood and the strength of the phoenix it came from, it can grant even a mortal over 10,000 years of longevity without needing to cultivate!"

'Heal any illness or injuries...?' A profound expression appeared on Yuan's face when he heard that, and an idea immediately appeared in his mind.

'If the Translucent Dew of Flawlessness affected my body in real life, maybe this phoenix blood could also heal my illness? Even if it's only a possibility, I must obtain this phoenix blood at all cost!'

"Umm... What do you want in exchange for the phoenix blood?" Yuan decided to ask her.

"You want this phoenix blood?" Madam Feng looked at him with a surprised face, as did Yu Rou and Xiao Hua. Why does he want the phoenix blood?

"Yes..." Yuan nodded.

"Hmm... I don't really know... I have had countless offers before, but none of them managed to attract me, and I don't have anything in mind for now." Madam Feng said.

"How about the other Divine-grade treasures? Xiao Hua can give you all of them for the phoenix blood." Xiao Hua suddenly chimed in.

Since this is her first time seeing such intense desire from Yuan's eyes, she wanted to do her best to assist him.

"I'm sorry, Senior, but I would prefer something else..." Madam Feng apologized to her.

"If you don't say what you want then how are we supposed to know what to trade?" Yu Rou asked with a slight frown on her face.

"Well... Although I have never really thought about what I wanted in exchange for the phoenix's blood, I think I have something in mind now..." Madam Feng spoke in a nervous tone, and she turned to look at Yuan afterward.

"Huh?" Yuan raised his eyebrows after noticing her gaze, but he soon realized what she wanted from him.

"You... want my blood?" he asked her.

"..." Madam Feng did not immediately respond and remained silent for a long moment before nodding her head in an embarrassed manner.

"Okay, how much do you want?" Yuan immediately agreed. "As long as it doesn't kill me, I'll give you however much blood you want."

"R-Really?" Madam Feng's eyes flickered with excitement.

"B-Brother... are you really going to...?" Yu Rou looked at him with disbelief. Although it may appear quite the bargain to obtain real phoenix blood by exchanging his own blood, this entire situation appeared extremely suspicious, as it was simply too good to be true.

"Yes, it's fine. It's only my blood. It'll return sooner or later," Yuan nodded.

He then looked at Madam Feng and continued, "How do you want to draw my blood?"

"Uh... I was just thinking about drinking it straight from your body..." she said.

"Drinking it straight from my body?" Yuan trembled in fright after hearing her words.

'This is for the phoenix blood! I must endure it!' Yuan cried inwardly before nodding.

"Go ahead." He lifted his arm, showing her his pale and smooth arms.

Seeing this, Madam Feng unconsciously licked her luscious red lips.

"..."

Yuan trembled even more after seeing this. Thinking to himself that Madam Feng being a vampire was becoming more and more likely.

"If you do anything suspicious to Brother Yuan, Xiao Hua will not hold back this time like previously," Xiao Hua suddenly warned her with narrowed eyes.

"I-I wouldn't dare, Senior..." Madam Feng said with a fearful expression.

"Why don't we go somewhere more comfortable?" Madam Feng then suggested to Yuan.

After Yuan nodded, Madam Feng said, "Follow me."

Sometime later, they entered this room that was behind some curtains on the 6th floor, and it was clearly Madam Feng's personal room, as the room was filled with furniture and even a large bed.

"Please take a seat on the bed," Madam Feng pointed at the large red bed.

"Okay." Yuan nodded and sat on the bed without hesitation.

Madam Feng then sat beside him with Yu Rou and Xiao Hua standing a few meters away.

"Whenever you're ready," Madam Feng said to him in a gentle voice.

Yuan nodded before using the Starry Abyss to cut a small opening on the lower area of his palm, and blood immediately began flowing out.

Madam Feng quickly grabbed his hand and kissed his wound with her soft lips, not letting even a single drop of his blood go to waste.

"Mmm..."

Erotic noises came from Madam Feng as she savored Yuan's blood that was incomprehensibly delicious for some reason, and just a single drop of it made Madam Feng completely addicted to it.

Meanwhile, Yuan tried his best to keep a poker expression on his face, but the feeling of Madam Feng's soft lips was simply too stimulating, especially her tongue that was gently licking his wound, almost like a dog.

"Why do you think she likes my brother's blood so much? Is she actually a vampire disguised as a human?" Yu Rou whispered to Xiao Hua as they watched.

Xiao Hua shook her head and said, "No, she's not a vampire. As for why she's consuming Brother Yuan's blood... Xiao Hua can think of a few."

"Brother Yuan's blood may be special— perhaps he has a unique bloodline that has the effect of making people addicted to it."

"Huh? Is that even possible?" Yu Rou looked at her with wide eyes.

Xiao Hua nodded and said, "There are many unique bloodlines in this world, and some of them have powerful and incomprehensible effects, such as having blood that can increase magical beasts cultivation or blood that can strengthen even treasures."

"Wow..." Yu Rou expressed her awe after hearing what bloodlines could do.

"But if my brother's blood can affect humans, why aren't we affected by it?" Yu Rou then asked.

"Perhaps it only affects some people, like how some medicines work better on some than others," Xiao Hua said.

"That makes sense..." Yu Rou nodded.

Many minutes later, Yuan was beginning to feel lightheaded, so he tapped Madam Feng's shoulders and said, "I think I am at my limit... If I lose any more blood, I'll probably die from blood loss..."

"Aaaahhh~!"

Madam Feng removed her lips from his wound a few seconds later, even releasing a loud and satisfied sigh, sounding as though she'd just drank something delicious.

"Thank you, esteemed guest... I don't know why I crave for your blood, but I am now satisfied." Madam Feng said to him.

"..."

However, Yuan did not respond.

"Esteemed guest?" Madam Feng noticed that Yuan was staring at her with wide eyes, so she called him again.

"Your eyes... they changed colors..." Yuan said to her, whose brown eyes had suddenly turned golden after drinking his blood.

"Eh?"

Madam Feng immediately rushed to look for a mirror after hearing Yuan's words, almost like she was in a panic.

"It's gold... It's really golden!" Madam Feng suddenly exclaimed in an excited voice, dumbfounding the people in the room. "Hahaha! It has returned! My powers have returned!"

"Powers...?" Yuan raised his eyebrows in a puzzled manner, wondering what she was talking about.

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Chapter 90 - Vermilion Phoenix

"It's a miracle! My powers are starting to return! Hahaha!" Madam Feng danced around like an excited little girl after seeing her golden eyes in the mirror.

Meanwhile, Yuan and the other two girls were staring at her with a dazed look on their faces.

What was she so excited about? What did she mean by 'her powers are back' when she's already at the Spirit Grandmaster realm?

"Umm... are you okay?" Yuan suddenly asked her.

"Hm?" Madam Feng immediately turned to look at Yuan, but her gaze towards him had changed significantly compared to previously, almost like she was seeing him in a new light!

She turned around and walked to him very quickly before stopping a meter away and lowering her body until both her knees were on the floor, and she proceeded to press her forehead onto the floor made of marble, kowtowing to Yuan.

"Esteemed guest... No, Young Master... Thank you very much for restoring my powers even if it's only slightly!" Madam Feng said to him.

"I... I don't really understand," Yuan said while scratching his head.

Madam Feng then said, "To tell you the truth, I am not exactly human. In fact, I am a Divine Beast—the Vermilion Phoenix."

"You're a phoenix?!" Yuan exclaimed in a shocked voice.

"No way..." Even Yu Rou and Xiao Hua were startled by this reveal by Madam Feng.

"Yes, however, due to some circumstances, my bloodline was cursed, and my powers have been sealed and I am forced to live my life as a human. I have been living such a life for over 10,000 years now." Madam Feng continued to reveal even more secrets about herself that she'd kept a secret for over 10,000 years.

"10,000 years!" Yuan cannot imagine living for so long and was greatly shocked to hear that Madam Feng had this much experience.

"So your powers have returned, huh? That's great to hear," Yuan said with a smile.

"Yes... But it's only a small amount, and I can still feel the curse restricting my body." Madam Feng sighed.

And then she lifted her head to look at Yuan with a hopeful gaze and continued, "However, Young Master... I believe your blood can help me remove this curse and allow me to be free once again."

"My blood?" Yuan raised his eyebrows in a surprised manner.

"Yes. For some reason, I am attracted to your blood, and after drinking it, my curse weakened, so I can only assume that your blood has the ability to remove my curse." Madam Feng said.

"Therefore, I plead the Young Master for help! Please help get rid of this curse that has trapped me in this Lower Heavens for 10,000 years! I will do anything in return!"

After a moment of silence, Yuan spoke in a calm voice, "If my blood can really help you remove your curse, I would gladly help by giving you as much blood as you need. However, it requires time for my blood to recover, and I don't have the time to wait around, not to mention who knows how much blood you will need to fully remove that curse."

"That's right. Brother Yuan will soon climb the Stairway to Heaven until he reaches the peak. He doesn't have the time to linger in this small place," Xiao Hua also chimed in.

"Stairway to Heaven...?" Madam Feng looked at him with surprise, and she became silent.

"Are you okay?" Yuan asked her after she remained silent for a minute.

After blinking her eyes in a dazed manner a few times, Madam Feng suddenly said to Yuan, "Young Master... if you cannot stay here, then I will follow you until I am free of my curse! Of course, I won't selfishly request your help free of charge! Everything in this store—including myself—I shall bestow to the Young Master! As long as you let me follow you and consume your blood occasionally, you can do whatever you want with these treasures or my body!"

"Everything in this store?" Yuan looked at her with a gawking expression. He cannot imagine obtaining so many expensive treasures at once, and all he needed to do was share some of his blood.

"I won't ask you to give your treasures since I don't need so many treasures that I cannot use, and I don't want to feel greedy—like I'd taken advantage of you, who is currently in a bind because of a curse. I am satisfied with just the Phoenix Blood," Yuan said with a gentle smile on his face.

"..."

Seeing Yuan's blinding smile, Madam Feng narrowed her eyes before bowing to him again. "Thank you, Young Master!"

Madam Feng then said, "Young Master, may I have some of your blood again? Just a single drop will do."

Yuan nodded and extended his arm.

Madam Feng lifted her head and licked the wound on Yuan's palm.

A second later, the wound immediately disappeared, and a few more seconds later, a notification appeared before Yuan.

«Vermilion Phoenix has initiated a temporary servant contract with you!»

"Young Master, this one's full name is Feng Yuxiang or Feng Feng for short. Until my curse is lifted, I shall swear my allegiance to the Young Master and heed your every command without any complaints, and the Young Master can use my body as he pleases. Will the Young Master allow me to stay by your side?"

"Yes, I don't mind." Yuan nodded. It would benefit him to have another powerful ally by his side, anyway.

«You have accepted Vermilion Phoenix as your Servant!»

Name: Feng Yuxiang

Servant Grade: Divine

Master: Yuan

Cultivation: Ninth Level Spirit Grandmaster

Legacy: None

Bloodline: Ancient Phoenix Bloodline

Physique: Inextinguishable Immortal Fire

—

«Phoenix Fire»

«Rank: Heaven»

«Mastery Level: 5»

—

«Superior Sense»

«Rank: Heaven»

—

«Qi Manifestation»

«Rank: Earth»

—

«Fly»

«Rank: Earth»

—

«Undying Flames»

«Rank: Divine»

—

«Fire Immunity»

«Rank: Divine»

—

«Cursed Bloodline»

«Rank: ???»

«Congratulations! Because you have obtained a Divine Beast as your Servant, you have been awarded the unique title 'Divine Beast Tamer'!»

After Yuan accepted Feng Yuxiang as his servant, an announcement appeared in the sky for every player to witness.

«Congratulations! Player Yuan has become the first player to obtain a Divine Beast Servant!»

The announcement immediately caused an uproar within the community, creating a wildfire on the internet shortly later.

"Divine Beast...?" Player White Lotus mumbled to herself as she stared at the announcement in the sky with a dazed expression on her face, and she turned to look at her Two-tailed Black Cat. As the first player to have obtained a Servant, she was naturally proud of herself. But after Player Yuan suddenly came out of the blue and obtained a Divine-grade Servant, her achievements were instantly overshadowed. Now that Player Yuan has obtained a Divine Beast, she might as well treat her achievement as though it'd never happened.

Meanwhile, back in Feng Yuxiang's room, Yu Rou and Xiao Hua were staring at Feng Yuxiang with a shocked expression on their faces.

"Brother... just obtained a phoenix as his Servant?" Yu Rou mumbled in a low voice. Although she couldn't help but be slightly envious of Yuan, she was also proud of him for yet another incredible achievement that will without doubt shake the entire world.

Xiao Hua, on the other hand, had an uncomfortable and indescribable feeling in her chest, almost like something important and special had been taken away from her.

"Thank you, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang said as she suddenly stood up and kissed Yuan on the cheeks.

"Ah!" Yu Rou shouted loudly after seeing this, her eyes wide with shock.

Sometime later, Yuan asked Feng Yuxiang, "I can call you Feng Feng, right? What are you going to do with this place if you are going to follow me?"

"Yes, the Young Master can address me as he pleases. As for the Phoenix Heaven, since I don't have anyone I trust enough to entrust them this place,

I will simply close the store down since I won't have the time to manage it anymore," she responded.

"I see..." Yuan nodded, and he continued a moment later, "By the way... the Phoenix Blood..."

"Here is the Phoenix Blood, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang then handed him the jade slip that contained the Phoenix Blood.

"Oh yeah... since you are actually the Vermilion Phoenix, does this mean this blood is yours?" Yuan suddenly asked her.

"That's right, Young Master," Feng Yuxiang nodded, and she continued, "However, the blood within that jade slip was extracted from my body before I was cursed, so you can also say it's no longer my blood."

"How does the curse work, exactly?" Yuan then asked her.

"Well, it seals my cultivation base and suppresses it, not allowing me to ascend to the next realm no matter how much I cultivate, hence why I have been stuck in the Spirit Grandmaster realm for over 10,000 years now."

"Furthermore, it puts a restriction on my bloodline, forcing me to remain in my human form, and I cannot transform back into my phoenix form until the curse weakens enough."

"Does this mean you are actually much stronger than your current self?" Yuan continued to ask.

"That's right, Young Master. My real cultivation base is actually much higher because I was born in the higher realms. I am only stuck in this place now because if I would not survive in the higher realms with my current strength." Feng Yuxiang nodded.

"However, my powers should return as the curse weakens. So while I cannot assist the Young Master much in my current state, once my curse weakens and my powers slowly return, I will be of more use to the Young Master in the future," she said.

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Chapter 91 - Unknown Bloodline

"If you don't mind me asking, how did you even get the curse in the first place?" Yuan suddenly asked Feng Yuxiang.

Hearing his question and recalling her history, Feng Yuxiang sighed in a depressed manner before speaking, "This is going to sound silly, but we phoenixes are born with extreme pride, but that pride sometimes turn into arrogance, and being the young phoenix I was back then, I'd accidentally offended someone I wasn't supposed to, so that person cursed my bloodline, sealing my powers..."

Yuan stared at her with a dumbfounded expression. She had her powers sealed and her bloodline cursed just because she offended someone? Just what kind of person did she offend? And how powerful must this person be to curse a phoenix's bloodline?

"At least you're being honest," Yu Rou suddenly approached them and said.

"By the way, what are you going to do with that Phoenix's Blood, brother?" she then asked him.

"I'm going to consume it, of course," he said.

"Eh? Why would Brother Yuan...?" Xiao Hua also approached them and looked at Yuan with a puzzled face. "Are you injured or sick somewhere, Brother Yuan?"

"N-No, not really," Yuan quickly shook his head.

"Then why do you need the Phoenix's Blood, Brother Yuan?" Xiao Hua tilted her head in a puzzled manner. "If you are not injured then it's about increasing your longevity... However, Brother Yuan is still very young and

nowhere near his limit. He doesn't need to use such a treasure to increase his longevity."

In Xiao Hua's view, only Cultivators who have reached the end of their longevity and also the limit of their growth would require obtaining longevity from treasures, as that is the only way they can continue living.

"Well... It's kind of complicated..." Yuan said with an awkward smile on his face. It was not as though he could tell them that he wanted to see whether the Phoenix's Blood could heal his body in the real world, as that would make him sound crazy.

"By the way, Young Master, I have been wondering, what kind of bloodline do you have? If your blood can weaken that person's curse, you must come from a powerful family that is even more powerful than that person, right?" Feng Yuxiang suddenly asked him.

"Bloodline...? But I don't have any unique bloodline," Yuan said— at least that's what his status says.

Yuan then opened his status to in case.

«Bloodline: None»

Indeed, he did not have any bloodline according to the system.

"That's impossible, Young Master, for you to not have a powerful bloodline. Normal blood would not attract a Divine Beast such as myself, much less weaken the curse from a powerful Cultivator in the upper heavens," Feng Yuxiang said to him with a puzzled face.

"I don't know what else to say since I really don't have any special bloodline and I am not from some powerful family," Yuan said.

Feng Yuxiang became silent with a pondering expression on her face. A few moments later, she spoke, "Although I didn't mention this before, my phoenix blood also has the ability to awaken bloodlines. In fact, all Divine Beasts have such ability. If you drink my blood, perhaps you will learn

more about your bloodline. After all, not everyone is born with their bloodline awakened. Some must fulfill requirements or require assistance from treasures in order to awaken their bloodlines."

"Really?" Yuan raised his eyebrows. Perhaps that's why the system cannot recognize his bloodline, as it has yet to awaken.

"Anyway, we'll know whether I have a bloodline or not after I consume the phoenix blood. I just have to break the jade slip, right?" Yuan asked Feng Yuxiang.

"Allow me to help you, Young Master."

Yuan nodded and handed her the jade slip.

Feng Yuxiang then placed the jade slip above Yuan's head and said, "Open your mouth, Young Master."

Yuan lifted his head and opened his mouth.

Feng Yuxiang then snapped the jade slip in half, and a single drop of golden blood escaped from the jade slip, falling directly into Yuan's throat.

A few seconds later—

«You have consumed a drop of Vermilion Phoenix Blood»

«You have gained 50,000 years of longevity from consuming Vermilion Phoenix Blood»

«All of your injuries and illness has been cured»

«The Vermilion Phoenix Blood is reacting to your Bloodline»

«Attempting to awaken Bloodline»

«...»

«...»

«...»

«Failed»

«Attempting to awaken Bloodline again»

«...»

«...»

«...»

«Failed»

«Final attempt to awaken Bloodline»

«...»

«...»

«...»

«Failed»

«Vermilion Phoenix Blood is too weak to awaken your Bloodline»

«Heaven Refining Physique activated»

«Vermilion Phoenix Blood has been refined»

«You have obtained the skill 'Superior Regeneration' from refining Vermilion Phoenix Blood»

«Superior Regeneration»

«Rank: Heaven»

«Description: Greatly improves all of your regeneration abilities.»

"Uhh..." Yuan looked at Feng Yuxiang afterward and said, "I think the Vermilion Phoenix Blood is too weak to awaken my Bloodline."

"What?! My blood is too weak?!" Feng Yuxiang exclaimed in a shocked voice.

"That's outrageous! My blood has the capabilities to awaken all Bloodlines below the Divine-grade!"

However, Feng Yuxiang suddenly turned silent, and she continued a moment later, "Actually, that would make sense since your blood was able to weaken that person's curse, so it's not too far-fetched to say your Bloodline is above the Divine-grade..."

Feng Yuxiang looked at Yuan with a gaze of admiration and even a hint of fear within her eyes. People who are born with Bloodlines above the Divine-grade are too far and few in-between, and only extremely powerful families in the upper heavens have the capabilities to give birth to someone with such a powerful Bloodline. Just who is Yuan? What kind of powerful cultivation family is he from?

"Brother Yuan has a Bloodline that's above Divine-grade?" Xiao Hua also looked at Yuan with wide eyes filled with shock. It has been a while since she felt this way—probably not ever since she first witnessed Yuan consuming monster cores.

While Feng Yuxiang and Xiao Hua stared at Yuan with dazed looks on their faces, Yu Rou spoke, "What are the grades for Bloodlines? Though, I can already imagine how powerful Divine-grade is just by its name..."

"There are many grades for Bloodlines. The lowest grade would be Royal-grade, then Imperial-grade, and finally, Divine-grade. Of course, there are still much more powerful Bloodlines that are above the Divine-grade such as the Ancient-grade, but you only see people with that kind of Bloodline in the upper heavens, not a small place such as the Lower Heavens," Feng Yuxiang explained.

"And since my Vermilion Phoenix Blood could not awaken the Young Master's Bloodline, it means that his Bloodline is above the Divine-grade and too powerful for my blood to do anything."

"Then what could possibly awaken my Bloodline?" Yuan asked her out of curiosity.

"Well... There are plenty of Divine Beasts that can awaken Bloodlines above the Divine-grade, such as the Heavenly Dragon and the Star Tortoise, but you won't find any of them in the Lower Heavens, as they only live in the upper heavens." Feng Yuxiang said.

"The upper heavens, huh," Yuan mumbled.

"Are you sure you're not from some powerful cultivation family from the upper heavens, Young Master? After all, there's simply no way an ordinary Cultivator would have such a powerful Bloodline— not even if they are the luckiest people in the world." Feng Yuxiang asked him again.

"Yes, I am sure." Yuan nodded.

"Hmm..." Feng Yuxiang narrowed her eyes at him. Of course, she didn't fully believe him. But since Yuan didn't want to tell her, she won't continue asking, as she was afraid that it might anger him.

"Anyway, I still have to close down this store before I can leave this place. Can you spare me a few hours, Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang asked him afterward.

"Go ahead, we'll be here." Yuan nodded.

"Thank you, Young Master! Then I'll try to get this over with as soon as possible!" Feng Yuxiang then left the room and began closing the store down.

Meanwhile, Yuan said to Yu Rou, "Yu Rou, don't you have piano lessons to attend to today?"

Yu Rou shook her head and said, "No, there are no lessons on Sundays. However, I still have to cook you breakfast, so I'll do that now."

"Okay," Yuan nodded.

After Yu Rou logged off to prepare breakfast, Xiao Hua suddenly spoke, "Brother Yuan, can we really trust that woman?"

"Feng Feng? I think so," he nodded with a calm expression. "Why? Do you not trust her?"

"Well... she has done some unfavorable things..." Xiao Hua said.

"I guess her first impression isn't exactly the best. However, I can feel that she's not a bad person at heart, just like you, Xiao Hua." Yuan said with a smile on his face, causing her to blush.

"Like Xiao Hua?" she mumbled.

"That's right. It's hard to explain it, but I can somehow tell whether someone is a good person or a bad person just by their aura—it's something that has been with me since I was young. While I haven't been around people for many years now, my ability still remains," Yuan said.

After a moment of silence, Xiao Hua nodded and said, "Since Brother Yuan trusts that bird, Xiao Hua will also believe in her. As for Brother Yuan's Bloodline, Xiao Hua will think of something."

"Thank you, Xiao Hua." Yuan said to her, and he continued, "Anyway, I will also log off for now. If Feng Feng returns before I do, just let her know that I will be back later."

Xiao Hua nodded, and Yuan logged off the next second with his heart throbbing with excitement, as he was impatient to see whether the Vermilion Phoenix Blood had affected his body in the real world just like the Translucent Dew of Flawlessness had.

Chapter 92 - Breakthrough?

After logging off Cultivation Online, Yuan immediately began trying to move his real body, hoping that the Vermilion Phoenix Blood had cured his illness and healed his crippled body.

But alas, he quickly realized that nothing had changed when he still couldn't move his limbs or see the world around him.

However, he was not discouraged, and he began reciting the cultivation technique inside his head, silently praying that it would work.

'Even if my body is still crippled, as long as I can cultivate...!'

With that thought in mind, Yuan proceeded to spend many minutes cultivating.

"..."

"..."

"...Ouch!"

The pain returned after a few moments of cultivation, but Yuan did not give up and tried again.

"...Ouch!"

And again.

"..."

"...Ouch!"

And again.

"...Ouch!"

"Why?! Why hasn't anything changed?! My body is still useless and I cannot cultivate! Why didn't the Vermilion Phoenix Blood work like the Translucent Dew of Flawlessness?! Damn it!" Yuan gritted his teeth in frustration and cried out in a low but deeply sorrowful voice after realizing that he was still crippled and useless, feeling as though his hopes had shattered.

However, right as tears flowed from his eyes, Yuan suddenly felt a warm feeling in his heart, almost as though there was a small flame within his heart.

This warm feeling gradually grew hotter and hotter, and it also began spreading throughout his body shortly later.

A few minutes later, Yuan could feel his entire body burning feverishly, almost like he was inside an oven with its temperature turned up.

However, this burning sensation did not feel painful, nor was it unpleasant.

'This is... Is this the effects of the Vermilion Phoenix Blood?' Yuan wondered to himself, feeling as though his body was engulfed in flames just like a burning phoenix.

Although Yuan did not know this at the time, his damaged meridians were actually being restored by the Vermilion Phoenix Blood, hence the burning sensation all over his body.

After sweating a bucket of sweat, the burning sensation in Yuan's body began to subdue, yet the gentle flame within his heart lingered no matter how long had passed, almost like an undying flame.

Once everything calmed down, Yuan took a moment to clear his mind and began reciting the cultivation technique again.

This time, Yuan could instantly recognize the difference, and the difference was as clear as day and night— like breathing with a blocked nose and breathing normally.

Furthermore, although there was still slight pain while he cultivates, it wasn't as painful as before and it was completely endurable even for long periods at a time.

And many minutes later, Yuan suddenly felt a refreshing feeling spread throughout his body starting from the center of his body until it reached the end of his limbs, making him recall the first time he'd become a Cultivator.

'This feeling... Did I become a Cultivator?' Yuan wondered to himself as he was unsure. Without the system telling him, he had no proof or confirmation that he had successfully become a Cultivator just now.

However, one thing he was certain would be his condition— even if he'd somehow managed to become a Cultivator in the real world, his body still remained crippled. With that being said, it was not as though nothing about his body had changed.

Although it was only slightly, his body had regained some sense of feeling, allowing him to feel the wet blanket and his own sweat when he previously wouldn't have been able to feel a thing except for the weight of the blankets.

"It worked! Hahaha! It really worked!" Yuan began laughing out loud at his success.

"What worked?" Yu Rou suddenly returned to the room with breakfast.

"Oh... Nothing..." Yuan said. He was simply not ready to tell her just yet.

'Just wait a little longer, Yu Rou... Once I can finally start moving again...'
A mysterious smile appeared on Yuan's face.

"Ah! Brother Tian! Why is your body soaked in sweat?!" Yu Rou immediately realized the wet blankets and exclaimed.

"Eh? I guess it's a little hot in here..." Yuan said with a weird smile on his face.

Yu Rou immediately removed the wet blanket from his body and tossed it on the floor.

"Let's quickly finish breakfast before you catch a cold..." Yu Rou said as she began feeding him soup for breakfast.

A few minutes later, Yu Rou called the servants to change the blankets and clean the bedsheets whilst she took Yuan to the bathroom to give him a quick shower.

While being cleaned by Yu Rou, Yuan could faintly feel her hands rubbing his body, indicating that his senses were truly beginning to return.

'Ahhh... How long has it been since I last felt such sensations on my body?' Yuan sighed inwardly, feeling like he was on cloud nine.

However, a weird and unfamiliar sensation appeared in his body when Yu Rou began cleaning the area below his waist, especially the area between his legs. Although he couldn't understand why, it felt unfathomably awkward, and he could feel a chill going down his spine.

This weird sensation would continue to linger in his body for some time, as Yu Rou seemed to be especially focused on cleaning around that area.

Sometime later, he could feel the water rinsing his body.

And then he felt a strong wind blowing on his body.

By the time Yu Rou finished cleaning Yuan, the servants had long cleaned the bedsheets and blankets in Yu Rou's room, allowing them to sleep on it again.

"I made sure the blankets this time are not as heavy so you don't sweat like that again," Yu Rou said to him before they entered the cultivation world again.

"Hm? Looks like Feng Feng is still trying to close the store," Yuan said after not seeing her face in the room.

While they waited for Feng Yuxiang to finish closing the store, Yuan asked Xiao Hua, "How can someone who just became a Cultivator tell that they have actually become one?"

Although Xiao Hua was confused as to why he would ask such a basic question, Xiao Hua still answered him regardless, "When someone becomes a Cultivator for the first time, they will be able to feel a burst of spiritual energy within their body."

"It's that refreshing feeling, right?" Yuan asked.

"That's right." Xiao Hua nodded.

"What else?"

"Well... They will be able to sense the spiritual energy in the air. If one cannot feel Spirit Qi, then it means they are not a Cultivator yet."

'Ah! That's right! Feeling the spiritual energy in the air! How could I forget such a basic thing!' Yuan sighed inwardly. His excitement from cultivating successfully had messed with his ability to think properly.

After asking Xiao Hua a few more basic questions about Cultivators, Yuan sat on Feng Yuxiang's bed and cultivated while they waited for her to return.

A little over two hours later, Feng Yuxiang returned to the room with her body slightly glistening from sweat.

"I am sorry for making you wait so long for me, Young Master. I ran into some problems, but I have finally closed the store." Feng Yuxiang said to him.

If not for some reluctant people begging her to stay in Phoenix City, she would've completed her errands much quicker. Though, as one of the top figures and the owner of one of the most famous stores in Phoenix City, it

was only a given that her sudden departure would shock a lot of people in the city, especially the powerful families and individuals.

"Don't mind it." Yuan said, and then he continued, "By the way, I have another question regarding your Vermilion Phoenix Blood. Does it have any effects besides healing injuries, increasing longevity, and awakening Bloodlines?"

"Hmm... Another effect, huh?" Feng Yuxiang immediately closed her eyes to ponder.

After thinking for a good minute, she suddenly opened her eyes and said, "Oh. That's right. My blood can also heal one's meridians."

'Restore meridians? Xiao Hua did mention something like that before. Perhaps that was the reason for my frustration. Now that her blood has restored my meridians, I can finally cultivate!'

After pondering for a moment, Yuan turned to look at Feng Yuxiang before approaching her with a wide smile on his face.

"Thank you, Feng Feng! Although you may not realize it, you have saved my life with your blood! In return, no matter how much blood you want from me or when you want it, I will gladly give it to you!" Yuan suddenly opened his arms and hugged Feng Yuxiang's slender body tightly, his voice filled with joy.

"Y-Young Master?!" Feng Yuxiang panicked when Yuan suddenly embraced her, as she could immediately feel Xiao Hua glaring daggers at them. However, she also didn't dare to push Yuan away, as that could be regarded as being disrespectful! Furthermore, she has already told Yuan that he could do whatever he wanted to his body, and pushing him away would contradict her promise!

Sometime later, once Yuan expressed all of his excitement through the embrace, he released Feng Yuxiang, who appeared to be sweating even more than a minute ago.

"Anyways, are you ready to come with us?" Yuan asked Feng Yuxiang afterward.

Feng Yuxiang nodded and said, "No matter where the Young Master goes, this one shall follow."

A second later, Feng Yuxiang's body suddenly became engulfed in beautiful golden flames until her body could no longer be seen, and her figure began shrinking until it was a small ball of golden flames.

While Yuan was dumbfounded, Feng Yuxiang—now a ball of golden flames—flew directly at Yuan's chest where his heart was located, disappearing from the room and into his chest, and Yuan could feel a warm sensation in his heart afterward, almost like his heart was also engulfed in flames.

'This sensation...' The warm and pleasant feeling in his heart was very familiar, and it quickly reminded him of a similar feeling that could be felt in his real body.

Chapter 93 - A Frenzied Crowd

"Are you okay, Brother Yuan? Are you feeling any pain?" Xiao Hua asked him after Feng Yuxiang entered his body.

Yuan patted his body and nodded a moment later, "Yes, everything's fine. I am not hurt, nor does it feel unpleasant."

He then turned to look at Yu Rou and handed her all three Spirit Fruits and said, "Here's the Spirit Fruits. You'll need them to tame the beasts."

However, Yu Rou only accepted two of them and said, "You can keep the last one, brother. I just need an extra one for insurance."

Although Yuan didn't really need the Spirit Fruit, he nodded regardless. If Yu Rou ever needed another one, he can offer it to her again at that time.

After putting away the Spirit Fruit, Yuan said, "Then let's find you a Servant now."

However, Yu Rou shook her head and said, "No, it's fine, brother. There are only a few hours left before I have to prepare for school again. I'd rather spend this time just enjoying the game casually with you."

"Hmm..." Yuan immediately began to ponder.

A moment later, he spoke with a bright expression on his face, "I know! Why don't we go eat in some restaurant? I bet you still haven't experienced the amazing food in this world!"

"Food, huh? I heard you can taste the food as though it was real," Yu Rou nodded with interest.

"That's right. And they are incredibly tasty," Yuan said in an excited voice.

"Okay, let's go." Yu Rou agreed a moment later.

They left the room shortly later and began walking downstairs. When they reached the fifth floor, they realized that all of the display cases were empty and the treasures had been taken out. However, that was expected, as Feng Yuxiang had closed this store down.

Once they reached the first floor, Yuan spoke out loud, "Feng Feng, what should we do about this place?"

A moment later, Feng Yuxiang's voice resounded in his mind, almost like she was living inside his head, "You can just leave it as it is, Young Master. The next manager will take care of everything."

"I understand," Yuan nodded.

"Is she talking to you from inside? How come I can't hear her voice?" Yu Rou asked him with a fascinated gaze.

"I am talking to the Young Master through Divine Sense," Feng Yuxiang's voice suddenly resounded in Yu Rou's head.

"Wow! How amazing! Talking to people directly in their minds... that's just like telepathy!" Yu Rou exclaimed.

A few moments later, they stepped outside the store. However, to Yuan's surprise, an entire crowd had gathered outside the store, feeling almost like there was a protest of some sort going on.

"W-What is going on here? Why are there so many people here?" Yuan was startled by the gathering that surrounded the entire front store, blocking his view.

Furthermore, all of these people had powerful auras or luxurious clothes around their bodies, indicating that they were all experts or from wealthy families.

"Who are you? Where is Madam Feng?"

The people outside immediately asked them after seeing them leave the store.

"Uhhh..."

Just as Yuan pondered how he should respond, Feng Yuxiang's voice resounded in his head, "Young Master, just tell them that I am currently sleeping in my room and that I do not wish to be disturbed for the time being if they want me to reconsider my decision."

Yuan then repeated her words to the people outside despite not knowing the context, "Um... Madam Feng is currently sleeping in her room, but she doesn't want to be bothered by anyone, or else she will not reconsider her decision."

The place instantly turned silent when they listened to Yuan's words.

"Let's calm down for now and let Madam Feng rest. I'm afraid that if we continue to linger outside her store, she'll really leave the city..." One of them suddenly said.

"Yes, you're right. The city will take a huge hit if Madam Feng or her store suddenly disappears. We cannot take this matter lightly."

"Well, what do you suggest we do then? We cannot just let her leave like this!"

"No idea, but do you think Madam Feng's sudden decision was due to that powerful spiritual energy not long ago? She announced her leave shortly afterward, after all. I would not be surprised if she'd been forced to leave this city!"

"What kind of nonsense are you talking about? Madam Feng is the strongest individual in this city who has been around for over 1,000 years! Who could possibly threaten her, much less force her to leave?"

"Even if someone can threaten Madam Feng, what's there to fear? The entire Golden Phoenix Bazaar has her back! If someone dares to mess with one of us, they'll definitely regret it!"

"Do not underestimate whoever released that pressure! I was here when it happened, and it nearly gave me a heart attack! That individual is extremely strong— much stronger than Madam Feng and everyone here!"

"I believe that the individual who threatened Madam Feng to leave is a Cultivator at the Spirit King level."

"Spirit King? Why the hell would someone like that be here? Cultivators above the Spirit Grandmaster realm may stay in this world for at most 100 years after their breakthrough before they must leave this realm and ascend to a higher realm, or else they will risk being punished by the Heavens!"

"Unless you are telling me that this person had managed to reach the Spirit King realm in 100 short years after breaking through Spirit Grandmaster!"

"I am not lying to you! The pressure really felt that powerful!"

While the people gathered outside the store argued with each other, Yuan took this chance to slip away from the Golden Phoenix Bazaar with Yu Rou and Xiao Hua following behind.

"Man, that was chaotic. Just how popular are you, Feng Feng?" Yuan wiped the cold sweat from his forehead after managing to escape from that frenzied crowd.

"I have been in this city ever since I came down here from the upper heavens, and due to my high cultivation, people quickly began looking up to me as some sort of guardian for the place." Feng Yuxiang explained to him. "My reputation eventually peaked, and I am somewhat revered by the people in that city."

After a moment of silence, she continued, "However, none of that matters now, as I have the Young Master. By the way, Young Master, I know you said that you don't want my treasures, but if you ever change your mind,

just let me know. Although the treasures are valuable, it's nothing compared to the freedom you are giving me, Young Master."

"Un." Yuan nodded.

After leaving the Golden Phoenix Bazaar, Yuan asked Feng Yuxiang, "Do you know any good place to eat, Feng Feng? Since you've been here forever, you should know every building in this city, right?"

"I'm sorry, Young Master, but I rarely leave the Golden Phoenix Bazaar. However, there is this place that I have heard numerous times from others throughout the years— it's a restaurant called Phoenix's Nest."

"Phoenix's Nest? People really like using the name Phoenix in this city, huh." Yu Rou said.

"Well, I kind of did save this city from a very powerful beast before when I still had some of my Phoenix powers left. The city used to be called something else before." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Oh? You saved an entire city? Then you're just like my brother." Yu Rou smiled.

Sometime later, after asking around, Yuan and the others finally reached the restaurant named Phoenix's Nest.

"How many will be dining today, esteemed guests?" The waiter by the door greeted them when they approached the restaurant's entrance.

"Three," Yuan said.

"Three, right? Please follow me."

The waiter then brought them to a small table and said, "That is the menu. Just raise your hand when you're ready to order and someone will be with you."

"Thank you," Yuan said as he grabbed the menu and began flipping through the pages.

"Just order whatever you want," Yuan said to Yu Rou.

However, Yu Rou sat there with a dazed expression on her face, seemingly in deep thoughts.

"What's the matter, Yu Rou? Is something bothering you?" Yuan asked her after noticing her strange behavior.

Hearing his question, Yu Rou quickly snapped out of her daze and shook her head before speaking, "That's no it, brother. It's just that... I never thought the day would come where the two of us would be sitting in a restaurant and eating food like a normal family. Even though this is just a game, it feels too real to ignore."

"Yu Rou..." Yuan looked at her with a soft gaze, and he nodded, "You are right. While this world may not be real, our experience and feeling in this world certainly are, and I cannot wait to explore more of it with you."

"Me, too, brother!" Yu Rou nodded with a bright smile on her beautiful face.

Sometime later, Yuan raised his hands and someone approached them to take their order.

Yuan then proceeded to name dishes after dishes, dumbfounding both Yu Rou and the waiter.

"C-Can you even eat that much?" Yu Rou stared at him with a gawking expression. If Yuan could eat that much in the real world, she would definitely have trouble feeding him every day.

"Of course, or else I wouldn't be ordering it!" Yuan replied to her with a confident expression on his face before he returned to order more dishes.

Chapter 94 - Exploring The City Peacefully

After spending a couple of minutes naming out nearly every dish on the menu, Yuan finally placed the menu down on the table and said, "That's all from me."

The waiter there had the urge to cry out loud, 'It's literally all from you!'

Fortunately, the waiter managed to suppress his thoughts and responded with a stiff smile on his face, "Thank you, esteemed guests. I will let the chief know..."

The waiter then walked away.

However, the waiter returned a few minutes later with a middle-aged man who didn't appear to work there with his luxurious appearance.

Once the two were standing by their table, the middle-aged man said with a friendly smile on his face, "Excuse me, esteemed guest. My name is Cen Wenben, and I am the manager of this restaurant. It appears that you have ordered a massive amount of food from us, and I would like to offer my gratitude for that. However, as there has been an increase of customers who dine and dash lately, we will have to require some payment up-front as a form of insurance. 50 percent of the total amount is enough."

"That makes sense..." Yuan nodded his head and asked, "How much is the entire bill?"

"5,400 gold coins, esteemed guests..." Cen Wenben quickly said.

"5,400 gold coins?!" Yuan's eyes widened with surprise. This restaurant is at least 10 times more expensive than the luxurious restaurant he went to previously that had cost him 500 gold coins! As expected of one of the wealthiest cities in this world, everything is incredibly expensive!

'I really need to start paying attention to the price of each item...' Yuan noted to himself as he retrieved 5,400 gold coins and handed them to the manager.

"I'll pay the full amount now."

"Thank you, esteemed guest! And I deeply apologize for this inconvenience!" The smile on Cen Wenben's face widened after he accepted the money, and he bowed to them before leaving them alone again.

"Spending thousands of gold on food... only someone like you would be able to spend so luxuriously, brother..." Yu Rou said to him afterward.

"Haha..." Yuan laughed awkwardly, as he was too excited and forgot to look at the prices before it was too late. Though, at least he wasn't as poor as before, where 500 gold coins were enough to make him completely broke.

About twenty minutes later, the food they ordered began coming in one at a time, and they immediately started eating the food, especially Yuan, who had essentially become a food monster and stuffed the food into his mouth as though they were nothing, allowing the waiters to continue putting dishes on the table without overfilling it.

"Brother..." Yu Rou was shocked by his seemingly borderless stomach. How can so much food fit inside his body? It also made her worry that she might not be feeding him enough in the real world since the amount of soup she feeds to him is literally nothing compared to the amount he's gobbling up now— almost like comparing a drop of water to an entire ocean.

"Brother Tian, should I increase the amount of soup I feed you? If it's not enough, you can just tell me, you know? I'm afraid that I might starve you to death after seeing how much you can eat right now..." Yu Rou said to him sometime later.

"Haha... Don't worry about it, Yu Rou. I only have this appetite whenever I am in this world. A single bowl of soup is more than enough to fill my stomach outside." Yuan said to her.

Hearing their conversation, Xiao Hua suddenly spoke, "Brother Yuan's appetite is probably caused by his unique physique. Furthermore, because Cultivators expend a lot more energy than normal people, we also need to eat a lot more. Of course, we usually substitute the difference with the spiritual energy we absorb with some Cultivator even changing their diet to spiritual energy only."

"So you're telling me that Cultivators can survive without food as long as they absorb the spiritual energy in the air?" Yu Rou asked.

"That's right. A Cultivator at Brother Yuan's level can last a month without food, but he'll need to drink water at least once a week. Once a Cultivator reaches the Spirit Grandmaster realm, they can stop eating or drinking entirely and survive only on spiritual energy." Xiao Hua said.

"I see..." Yu Rou nodded, and she returned to eating her food.

About an hour later, once the table had nothing but empty dishes left, Yuan said while patting his round stomach, "What should we do now, Yu Rou?"

"Can you even do anything besides sitting while in that state, brother?" Yu Rou responded with a smile on her face.

"I'll be fine," he nodded.

"Well, I am also full, so I don't feel like doing anything right now. However, I don't want to just sit around and do nothing, so let's explore this city until it's time for me to leave," Yu Rou suggested.

"Sounds good," Yuan said.

After sitting around for a few more minutes, Yuan and Yu Rou proceeded to walk around the city, almost like they were taking a stroll in the park.

Of course, there were a few young masters that wanted to disturb the sibling's peaceful time together when they saw the beautiful Yu Rou. However, before they could even approach them, like a guardian spirit, Xiao Hua pressured them with an invisible pressure, taking care of the trouble before it even began.

Although Xiao Hua saw Yu Rou as a rival for Yuan's attention, when she saw the joy on Yuan's face whenever he spoke with— or even looked at Yu Rou, she simply cannot allow anyone to disturb that happiness, as she feared that she might have to experience that cold aura coming from Yuan again whenever someone messes with Yu Rou in his presence, something that put chills in her body even now if she tried to remember his cold gaze.

After spending a few oddly peaceful hours within a city as large as the Phoenix City mostly due to Xiao Hua's protection, Yu Rou logged off the game to cook dinner for Yuan.

Yuan decided to stay in the game for a few more minutes to spend some time with Xiao Hua until it was time for dinner.

After logging off, Yu Rou began feeding him dinner.

However, after drinking his bowl of soup, Yuan spoke in a puzzled voice, "Yu Rou, did you make less soup today? My stomach isn't as full as it normally would be..."

It was an odd feeling to not be full after drinking a whole bowl of soup, as he would usually feel quite full afterward.

"Huh? That's not possible. I didn't change the amount," Yu Rou responded in a surprised voice.

"However, if you're still hungry, I can go ahead and make another bowl of soup for you..."

"No, it's fine. I'm not hungry, but I am also not full. It's that kind of feeling," Yuan said to her.

"Okay, then I will cook a little bit more tomorrow morning," Yu Rou nodded.

"By the way, your room is finally clean again, brother. However, since you're already here, let's sleep together for another night, as we don't usually do this."

"Okay," Yuan said.

"I'm going to make sure I am prepared for school tomorrow, you can go to sleep first." Yu Rou said to him before leaving the room.

Normally, Yuan would agree with her and go to sleep, but now that he has become a Cultivator in the real world too, he wanted to cultivate whenever he had the time. Although he wasn't sure that cultivating might help his condition, it wouldn't hurt to try.

'Maybe the reason the bowl of soup wasn't enough for me is because I am now a Cultivator, which will require me to consume more energy?' Yuan pondered to himself before he began reciting the cultivation technique inside his mind, slowly absorbing the spiritual energy around him.

'Xiao Hua was right, I can now sense the spiritual energy in this room now that I have become a Cultivator. This means I am not dreaming and that I have actually become a real Cultivator in this world too!' Yuan was filled with enthusiasm for the future.

Even if becoming a Cultivator won't help him move or see again, if he cultivated enough, maybe he'll also be able to use Divine Sense in this world, and that would be worth all of his effort.

And with that in mind, Yuan began to focus on cultivating.

Half an hour later, Yu Rou returned to the room, and she mistook Yuan's cultivation as sleeping since his breathing pattern was completely relaxed and seemingly rhythmic.

Since I was in the store at that time, I didn't see any announcements, but one should make the announcement if they made a Divine Beast their servant, right? Oh well, I'll see once I go online,' Yu Rou thought to herself as she began to surf the internet.

And as she'd expected, when she opened the forums, all she could see was 'Player Yuan' being mentioned in the titles, and his presence filled pretty much the entire page.

[Player Yuan makes the headlines again! And this time he's obtained a Divine Beast as a Servant!]

[Incredible! Player Yuan has obtained another Servant— a Divine Beast!]

[What grade could this Divine Beast possibly be?!]

[If you know Player Yuan, I am willing to pay 1 billion dollars if you can reveal his real identity to me!]

'One billion dollars, huh? That's quite the tempting offer, but alas, I wouldn't betray Brother Tian even if you offered me the world...' Yu Rou shook her head, and she began reading through all of the posts that mentioned Yuan.

Chapter 95 - Increased Appetite

While Yu Rou lost track of time as she was engrossed with the internet talking about her brother, Yuan was silently cultivating on the bed, slowly absorbing the spiritual energy in the room.

His cultivation speed compared to the game was incredibly slow, and it had taken him nearly two hours to enter the next level whilst it only took less than half an hour to reach second level Spirit Apprentice in the game.

'What are the cultivation stages in the real world, anyway? I doubt it's the same as the game. However, since I have no other references, I'll just follow the cultivation stages in Cultivation online,' Yuan thought to himself as he continued to cultivate even when Yu Rou entered the bed and went to sleep.

One hour... two hours... three hours...

Yuan spent the entire night cultivating, and by the time morning came, he had managed to breakthrough only two times, reaching third level Spirit Apprentice.

"Good morning, Yu Rou." Yuan greeted her the moment she woke up and rubbed her eyes.

"Brother...? You're awake early today..." she said to him in a drowsy voice.

Yuan merely smiled at her words, as he obviously didn't sleep the entire night. However, despite not getting any sleep, he was as energetic as ever—even feeling better than he normally would after a good night's sleep.

After spending a few minutes resolving herself to wake up, Yu Rou eventually left the bed and went to prepare for the day.

Yu Rou returned to the room an hour later with two bowls of soup and a wet towel to wash Yuan's face.

"Brother, I cooked two bowls of soup for breakfast today. If you cannot finish it, don't force yourself," she warned him before she began feeding him.

However, to her surprise, Yuan managed to finish both bowls of soup to the very last drop.

"Two bowls of soup... For some reason, I am still not full..." Yuan said in an awkward voice afterward.

"What? You're still not full? How is that even possible?" Yu Rou looked at him with wide eyes.

Why did his appetite suddenly increase so drastically? Is this somehow related to what has happened to him recently?

'I should let Doctor Wang know about this just in case there's something wrong... I also need some advice on his diet if it remains like this,' Yu Rou thought to herself.

"Brother, I know you're not full, but I am afraid of overfeeding you, so I'll have to ask for Doctor Wang's advice before I decide to feed you anymore, okay?" Yu Rou then said to him.

"Yes, that's fine. Like last night, while I am not full, I am also not hungry either," Yuan said.

"Okay, I'll let him know now before I go to school."

Sometime later, on her way to school, Yu Rou called Doctor Wang and explained to him about Yuan's situation.

"The Young Master's appetite suddenly increased, huh? This might actually be a good sign because that means his body is requiring more energy to function, and that usually happens when their body is growing stronger. I suggest you continue to feed him two bowls of soup for a few more days to

see if his growing appetite is permanent or only temporary." Doctor Wang said to her through the phone.

"If the Young Master's appetite is permanent, I suggest you increase his diet slowly without overfeeding him so that his body is getting the energy it requires. I will come to check on him once a week to monitor his body's condition just in case."

"I understand. Thank you, Doctor Wang."

Meanwhile, Yuan returned to the world of cultivation.

"Are you going to partake in the disciple examination at the Dragon Essence Temple now, Brother Yuan?" Xiao Hua asked him after he returned.

"That's right." Yuan nodded.

"Even though Brother Yuan will progress his cultivation base faster outside?" Xiao Hua asked him.

"My purpose for going to the Dragon Essence Temple is not to improve my cultivation base. Instead, I wish to expand my knowledge and experience with Cultivators so I can better deal with them in the future."

"I acknowledge that I am still far too naive in this world regarding Cultivators and their nature, and I want to understand this world more. Although it's important to improve my cultivation base it's also important that I enjoy this world, as that has been and still is my intention since the beginning."

Xiao Hua turned silent after hearing his words.

'Brother Yuan is indeed lacking experience when it comes to Cultivators. Although he might be fine now with Xiao Hua and that phoenix protecting him, who knows what might happen in the upper heavens, where there exists Cultivators much stronger than us. It'll definitely benefit Brother

Yuan in the long run the earlier he familiarizes himself with the competitive nature of Cultivators and realizes the brutal nature of the cultivation world.'

"Okay, Xiao Hua will no longer stop Brother Yuan from going to the Dragon Essence Temple now. However, it would lose all meaning if Xiao Hua is besides Brother Yuan the entire time while he's a disciple, so Xiao Hua will let Brother Yuan live his disciple life by himself. Of course, Xiao Hua will still protect Brother Yuan when he's in danger." Xiao Hua said to him.

"How are you going to protect me if you're not there?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

Xiao Hua then pointed at the necklace around his neck.

"Oh, that's right. You can go into the necklace like Feng Feng can enter my body," Yuan finally recalled.

"Anyway, do you know where the Dragon Essence Temple is located? Do you think we'll make it there before the examination begins? Although I can enter the sect without participating in the examination if I spoke to Xuan Wuhan's grandfather, I still want to experience it like how people normally would."

"The token given to you should tell you the location," Xiao Hua said, and she continued, "Just activate it with your spiritual energy, and its location will appear inside your mind."

Yuan followed her instructions and retrieved the Dragon Essence Temple Exam Token before activating it with his spiritual energy.

A few seconds later, an image of the Dragon Essence Temple and its location appeared inside his head like some sort of map.

However, Yuan immediately frowned when he realized just how far away this place was.

"It's over 100,000 miles away from our current location... Even the flying sword won't be fast enough. Unless we take the Teleportation Device again, I don't think we'll make it in time for the examination," he sighed.

"Allow me to help, Young Master."

Feng Yuxiang's voice suddenly resounded, and a small ball of golden flames emerged from his chest a second later.

"Feng Feng?" Yuan looked at her with raised eyebrows.

"I can carry the Young Master to the Dragon Essence Temple. It's only 100,000 miles. And I can fly much faster than a flying sword." Feng Yuxiang suggested to him.

"You'll... carry me?" Yuan looked at her with wide eyes.

"Unless the Senior wants to carry you, but with the difference in your sizes..." Feng Yuxiang looked at Xiao Hua whose head could not even reach Yuan's shoulders. She cannot imagine someone so tiny carrying Yuan who was almost twice her height. Actually, she can, but it would be an incredibly hilarious sight, but alas, laughing at Xiao Hua will definitely get her killed.

"..."

However, Xiao Hua still frowned after hearing Feng Yuxiang's words, as she hated her height being mentioned more than anything else.

Feng Yuxiang immediately began sweating after noticing Xiao Hua's narrowed gaze.

"A-Anyway... since I am also a phoenix, I can fly faster than Cultivators normally would be able to. 100,000 miles— we can arrive by tonight."

"By tonight?" Yuan began pondering.

'If we can reach there by tonight, it'll save us a lot of time— time I can use to cultivate in the real world...'

After pondering for a moment, Yuan nodded his head and said, "Okay, I'll have to trouble you for this one, Feng Feng."

"Don't even mention it, Young Master. My body is already yours— there's no need to thank me every time you use it," Feng Yuxiang said with a shameless smile on her face.

"Are you ready to leave now, Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang asked him a moment later.

"Yes."

"Then if you'll excuse me..."

Feng Yuxiang suddenly lowered her body and picked up Yuan, carrying him like a princess.

And before Yuan could even react, two massive fiery wings suddenly blossomed from Feng Yuxiang's back.

When the people around them saw this, they were immediately shocked.

"T-That's Madam Feng! What's she doing here?! And who's that young man she's carrying?!"

Feng Yuxiang ignored the uproar she caused and immediately flew towards the sky with Yuan screaming out loud like Yu Rou did when she first experienced flying with the flying sword.

"Which direction should I go, Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang asked him after they were above the entire city and nearly touching the clouds.

"That direction," Yuan pointed to the east according to the map in his head.

Feng Yuxiang nodded, and her fiery wings flapped once before they began soaring towards the east, leaving a trail of golden fire in the sky.

Meanwhile, Xiao Hua followed them from behind. However, even with her Spirit King cultivation base, she had to put a lot of effort in order to keep up

with their speed. Though, that was to be expected, as phoenixes are known to dominate the heavens with their flying techniques.

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Chapter 96 - Vermilion Phoenix

Dominating The Heavens

'This is amazing! We're flying at a speed ten times more than what the flying sword can achieve!' Yuan was filled with excitement as they soared through the air faster than even what most fighter jets in his world could achieve.

"If the Young Master thinks this is fast, just wait until I recover my phoenix form and powers. It'll be like comparing a slow walk to a sprint! 100,000 miles? I can even travel 1,000,000 miles in the blink of an eye!" Feng Yuxiang noticed Yuan's excitement and took this chance to brag a little to improve his impression of her.

"A million miles in the blink of an eye? How could anything possibly travel that fast?" Yuan mumbled in a dazed voice, as he cannot even begin to imagine traveling at such a ridiculous speed.

"It all depends on your movement techniques, Young Master. There are extremely profound movement techniques out there that can allow Cultivators to travel from star to star with a single step— it's not something even I can comprehend."

"Movement techniques, huh? Speaking of them, I don't have any movement techniques— only martial techniques." Yuan just realized this.

"What? The Young Master doesn't have a movement technique? That's outrageous!" Feng Yuxiang exclaimed in a shocked voice.

"Huh? Are movement techniques that important?" Yuan raised his eyebrows after seeing her surprised expression.

"Of course! Young Master, movement techniques are as important as martial techniques if not even more important! When you fight with an enemy, how you move to strike and how you move to dodge or defend is extremely important, or you will be no different than a sitting duck on the battlefield!" Feng Yuxiang said to him.

And she continued, "If the Young Master does not have a movement technique, I can provide you with my movement technique! Although it's meant for phoenixes, it can still be used in the human form."

"Really?" Yuan looked at her with flickering eyes, clearly excited for this movement technique.

"Of course."

Feng Yuxiang then turned to look at Xiao Hua and spoke to her, "Senior, you won't mind me giving the Young Master a movement technique, right?"

Because Feng Yuxiang didn't want to be disrespectful to Xiao Hua, who might be teaching Yuan as a teacher, she must ask for permission before teaching Yuan anything, as that is proper equities in the cultivation world, and trying to steal disciples from another is greatly frowned upon.

"..."

After a moment of silence, Xiao Hua nodded, "The more Brother Yuan learns the better. Xiao Hua does not have a good movement technique that is befitting of Brother Yuan's talent, so you can give one to him."

Since she was not Yuan's Master, she didn't mind other people teaching Yuan—as long as what they are teaching is not complete trash and worthless.

"Thank you, Senior! I will try my best teaching the Young Master!" Feng Yuxiang said to her.

Sometime later, after spending a few hours in the air, Feng Yuxiang suddenly stopped.

She then pointed in front of them with her head and said, "This place must be the Dragon Essence Temple. I can sense a profound presence coming from that place."

Yuan turned to look in the direction Feng Yuxiang was looking at to see a massive place that looked like a city but with a lot more buildings.

"So that's the Dragon Essence Temple, huh? It's so much larger compared to the Flying Sword Sect."

"I don't know a Flying Sword Sect, but the Dragon Essence Temple is one of the most powerful factions in the Lower Heavens only beaten by a few places and the Heaven and Earth Palace." Feng Yuxiang said.

Yuan nodded and said, "Anyway, the examination won't start for a few more days so let's spend some time practicing this movement technique."

"Okay, let me find a suitable place."

Feng Yuxiang proceeded to fly around the area until they found this empty land and descended there.

"This looks like the perfect place to practice my movement technique," Feng Yuxiang said as she placed Yuan back down.

Sometime later, Feng Yuxiang said, "Since this is something I learned naturally as the Vermilion Phoenix, I don't have it written on a scroll, so the Young Master will have to try and learn it from watching my movements. Although it might take you much longer to understand the technique this way than to read the technique straight from a book or scroll, at least you get to witness it being executed before your eyes. Of course, it could also benefit you if you are someone who learns better from watching than reading."

"Also, because this movement technique is not really meant for humans, it might take the Young Master longer to learn it. However, I believe in the Young Master. If you work hard enough, you should be able to use this technique in a few years."

"A few years?!" Yuan looked at her with wide eyes.

Feng Yuxiang misunderstood Yuan's type of surprise and said with a smile on her face, "I know a few years might sound a little too fast for a movement technique, but trust me, Young Master, I will do my best to teach you!"

However, Xiao Hua opened her mouth to speak afterward, "Your logic does not apply to Brother Yuan, Vermilion Phoenix. If you underestimate Brother Yuan, you'll be in a world of surprise."

"Huh?" Feng Yuxiang could not comprehend Xiao Hua's words and tilted her head in a puzzled manner. However, that was to be expected, since Feng Yuxiang is unaware of Yuan's heaven-defying comprehension abilities that allow him to learn even Divine-grade abilities in a few hours.

And before Xiao Hua could even explain, Yuan opened his mouth to speak, "Feng Feng, can you show me the movement technique?"

"R-Right away, Young Master!" Feng Yuxiang nodded, and she walked until she was many meters away from them.

"Watch closely, Young Master! I will try to do this as slowly as possible, but it might still be a bit fast!" Feng Yuxiang took a deep breath.

And then she began moving her legs and feet in a unique but rhythmic manner.

"This is a movement technique?" Yuan raised his eyebrows when he saw Feng Yuxiang's movement techniques, as it made no sense to him.

A few minutes later, Feng Yuxiang stopped and asked him, "What do you think, Young Master?"

"Uhhh... I don't think I understand it..." Yuan responded, and he continued, "How is that going to help you dodge your opponents during a battle? You are just moving around in a small area."

Feng Yuxiang pondered for a moment before speaking, "Young Master, why don't you try attacking me?"

"Huh? Are you sure?"

Feng Yuxiang nodded and said, "Yes."

"Okay..." Yuan retrieved his Spirit Sword and approached Feng Yuxiang.

"Young Master, you can attack me whenever you are ready. You also don't need to hold back." Feng Yuxiang said to him a moment later.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan said, "Here I come!"

Yuan began attacking Feng Yuxiang without any real sword techniques.

"Eh?"

However, Yuan quickly realized that no matter how much he tried to hit Feng Yuxiang, she would narrowly dodge all of his attacks.

"This is only the basics, Young Master. Let me show you what this movement technique can achieve with a high mastery level..."

Feng Yuxiang said to him before her fiery wings returned.

She then took a step towards Yuan before disappearing from his view, almost like a ghost.

"What do you think, Young Master?"

Feng Yuxiang's voice suddenly resounded from every direction around Yuan, causing him to look around. However, no matter which direction he looked in, Feng Yuxiang was there. In fact, there were over a dozen Feng

Yuxiang casually standing around him right now, almost like her body had multiplied.

"What the? This is a movement technique? Are you sure you didn't clone your body instead?" Yuan said with a dumbfounded expression.

Feng Yuxiang suddenly stopped moving, and a second later, her clones disappeared.

"I am just moving so fast that you are seeing a dozen of me," Feng Yuxiang said.

"So as long as I learn this movement technique, my opponents won't be able to hit me?" Yuan asked her afterward.

"That's correct. Unless they know your movement technique or can guess where you are going to move next, it's going to be extremely difficult for them to even graze you, much less land an accurate strike on you. And even if they somehow know your movements, they still need to be fast enough to hit you. As long as you are within the Lower Heavens, you will be untouchable with this movement technique."

"Untouchable..." Yuan mumbled in a low voice.

"By the way, this technique is called 'Vermilion Phoenix Dominating the Heavens'. I named it myself," Feng Yuxiang said with a prideful expression on her face.

"Vermilion Phoenix Dominating the Heavens? What an arrogant name for a movement technique..." Xiao Hua was speechless by Feng Yuxiang's shamelessness to give the movement technique such a grand name.

Sometime later, Yuan said to Feng Yuxiang, "Feng Feng, can you show me the movement technique a few more times? I have already memorized all of the movements, but I still need to understand its essence."

"Eh? You have already memorized the movements?" Feng Yuxiang looked at him with a dazed face.

There are over a thousand movements for the movement technique! How can someone at the Spirit Warrior level memorize that many movements in such a short time? That was simply unbelievable!

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Chapter 97 - Movement Technique

Seeing Feng Yuxiang's shocked face, Xiao Hua smiled and thought to herself, 'If you are shocked about something so insignificant, you might die from a heart attack after you see Brother Yuan's other talents...'

Meanwhile, Feng Yuxiang pondered to herself, 'Did the Young Master really memorize all of the steps after watching it just once? No... that's not possible. There's no way someone from the Lower Heavens can possibly have such a shocking level of talent. However, the Young Master has a Bloodline that's above the Divine-grade, and his origins are not clear, so he might actually be someone from the upper heavens who decided to come to the Lower Heavens for training, hence why there's a Spirit King following him.'

'However, even if that's the case... How can a Spirit King remain in the Lower Heavens without being punished by the Heavens with Heavenly Tributions? Maybe she has a treasure that hides her presence? But I have never heard of such a treasure like this before...'

"Are you okay, Feng Feng?" Yuan suddenly called out to her. "If you're tired, we can continue this later."

He wondered if she was tired after that impressive demonstration.

"Eh? N-No! I am fine. Let me show you the movements again, Young Master."

Feng Yuxiang took a deep breath before she began displaying the Vermilion Phoenix Dominating the Heavens movement technique again.

Meanwhile, Yuan stared at her with intensive eyes, looking as though he was trying to stare a hole in Feng Yuxiang's body.

'What an intensive gaze!' Feng Yuxiang's body trembled slightly after feeling Yuan's gaze, feeling as though there was nothing she could hide from him and almost like she was naked before his powerful gaze.

Many minutes later, Feng Yuxiang finished her demonstrating the movement technique for the second time.

"What do you think, Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang asked him afterward.

"I think I have the gist of it. Can you do it again? This time, I'll try to follow your movements." Yuan said as he approached her.

"You want to do the movement technique with me?" Feng Yuxiang raised her eyebrows, and she continued, "I don't mean to be disrespectful, Young Master, but even if you memorize all of the movements, executing the movements is an entirely different matter. Although you may get the first couple steps correct, everything after that will be a mess— at least that's how learning movement techniques usually happen."

"Well, even if that's the case, how else am I going to get better at it besides practice?" Yuan said to her.

"I guess so..." Feng Yuxiang nodded.

"Whenever you are ready, Young Master," she said to him a moment later.

"Go ahead."

After hearing his words, Feng Yuxiang began using her movement techniques again, and Yuan tried his best to follow her movements.

"..."

Feng Yuxiang was dumbfounded when Yuan copied her movements flawlessly, and although his movements grew stiff and awkward towards the end, he still managed to execute the movements without any mistakes.

This blew Feng Yuxiang's mind wide open. How can a mere mortal at the Spirit Warrior realm learn her— Vermilion Phoenix Dominating the

Heavens movement technique so quickly? She'd only displayed the movement technique twice!

"You were right, Feng Feng. Although the beginning was simple and easy to follow, it grew increasingly exhausting and difficult to move towards the end. However, I should get it right after a few more tries," Yuan said to her with an innocent face, unaware that what he'd just done was incredibly shocking and unbelievable.

"Uh... I... Err..." Feng Yuxiang was at a loss for words.

"Hehe..."

A small chuckle could be heard from Xiao Hua who watched the entire thing from beginning to end.

"Xiao Hua told you not to underestimate Brother Yuan, Vermilion Phoenix. He's a prodigy who can learn Divine-grade techniques in only a few hours and even learn profound techniques just by watching others," Xiao Hua said to her with a smile on her face.

"..."

Although this is Feng Yuxiang's first time seeing Xiao Hua smile, she was more shocked by what Xiao Hua said.

'The Young Master can learn Divine-grade techniques within hours? What kind of heaven-defying talent is that?' Feng Yuxiang stared at Yuan with a dazed expression on her face.

Sometime later, after resting until he could move again, Yuan began to execute the movement technique again.

This time, it appeared even smoother and more accurate than previously, almost like his experience with it had leaped by at least a few years between his first and second attempt!

Feng Yuxiang's jaw dropped upon seeing Yuan's improvement. Just how ridiculously talented is her Young Master? He could even put the talented

geniuses from the upper heavens to shame with his tremendous talents!

However, Xiao Hua suddenly said to her, "If you think that's the most shocking part about Brother Yuan, just wait until you see him do 'that'."

"That? What do you mean 'that', Senior?" Feng Yuxiang asked with her interest piqued.

"You'll find out eventually," Xiao Hua shrugged, as she wanted Feng Yuxiang to find out naturally as she did.

Feng Yuxiang swallowed nervously, and she silently pondered to herself what 'that' could possibly mean.

Meanwhile, Yuan spent the next hour practicing the movement technique.

"I think I finally got it, Feng Feng. What do you think?" Yuan asked her as his legs continued to move without stopping, feeling quite comfortable with the movement technique now.

"Y-Yes... You have pretty much learned the technique now, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang said, her gaze filled with admiration.

However, Yuan did not stop practicing the movement technique, and he continued until he finally received a notification.

«You have learned 'Vermilion Phoenix Dominating the Heavens'»

«Vermilion Phoenix Dominating the Heavens»

«Rank: Divine»

«Mastery Level: 1»

«Description: A powerful movement technique created by the Vermilion Phoenix Feng Yuxiang»

"Two hours... The Young Master managed to learn my movement technique that took me years to learn in just two short hours... Is he really human?"

Feng Yuxiang mumbled in a low voice as she watched Yuan perfect her movement techniques with a dazed expression on her beautiful face.

While she has seen her fair share of talented Cultivators in the upper heavens, none of them could compare to Yuan in terms of their comprehension skills, and even the top genius would need at least a month to learn Divine-grade techniques, much less a few hours!

After resting for a few minutes, Yuan said to them, "I am going to log off now, and I probably won't be back until the examination starts, so don't panic if I don't return tomorrow."

"Okay. See you later, Brother Yuan." Xiao Hua said to him before disappearing into the necklace.

Seeing this, Feng Yuxiang also disappeared into his chest.

Once he logged off the game, Yuan immediately began cultivating in the real world until Yu Rou returned from school and prepared dinner for him.

A few hours later, Yu Rou entered his room with three bowls of soup on a cart and some cleaning utilities.

"Brother, what did you do in the game today?" Yu Rou asked him as she removed the blanket around his body before removing his clothes and wiping his body down with a warm wet towel.

"I learned a new technique today— a movement technique," Yuan said.

"Movement techniques? What are those?" Yu Rou asked.

Yuan proceeded to explain to her about movement techniques and how they can be used to dodge attacks and many other things.

"Wow... So you learned another Divine-grade technique? As expected of you, brother. It's only been a day since you started playing alone again and you have already made significant progress. Perhaps I really am a burden to you..." Yu Rou sighed.

"Nonsense, you are definitely not a burden! If not for you, we would've never gone to Phoenix City or met with Feng Feng, not to mention the Myriad of Techniques, so you have definitely contributed to my progress!" Yuan said.

"If you say so..." Yu Rou nodded.

Sometime later, after cleaning Yuan's body, Yu Rou said, "Brother, since two bowls of soup was not enough yesterday, I have cooked three bowls of soup for tonight."

"Thank you, Yu Rou."

After feeding Yuan the second bowl of soup, Yu Rou asked him, "What do you think, brother? Can you eat another bowl?"

"Yes, I can," Yuan said.

"Okay." Yu Rou nodded and proceeded to spoon-feed him the third bowl of soup.

"What about now? Are you full now?" Yu Rou asked him afterward.

"Uh..." Yuan hesitated to respond.

Yu Rou raised her eyebrows when she saw this, and she said, "Brother, it's okay to tell me the truth. If three bowls of soup are not enough, I will cook four, five— until you are satisfied."

"..."

After a moment of silence, Yuan said, "Although I am not full, I actually feel like I ate something this time, so perhaps I will be full after two or three more bowls."

"Two or three more bowls... Heavens, brother, are you going to eat an entire week's worth of food every day now? Are you sure your body can handle that much food? What if you get fat?" Yu Rou spoke in a worried voice.

"Haha... I don't think you'll have to worry about that," Yuan said. After all, everything he eats will naturally turn into energy that will aid him in his cultivation.

And he continued, "However, I don't think I need to have a full stomach every meal. Just three bowls are good enough for now."

"Okay... Then I will continue feeding you three bowls of soup every meal until Doctor Wang gives his advice," Yu Rou nodded.

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Chapter 98 - Dragon Essence Temple Disciple Examination

After Yu Rou finished feeding Yuan, she said to him, "Okay, brother. Now that your own room has been cleaned, I am going to let you sleep by yourself again."

A few moments later, Yu Rou carried Yuan to the wheelchair before pushing him back to his own room.

"Do you want to play tonight, brother?" Yu Rou asked him.

Now that she knows his real identity as Player Yuan, she was more willing to let him play more so that he can continue progressing as much as possible.

"No, it's okay. In fact, I am going to take a break from Cultivation Online for a few days until the Dragon Essence Temple examination begins," Yuan said to her.

"Huh? You're taking a break already? Why?" Yu Rou asked him with a dumbfounded expression on her face.

Although missing a few days of progress might not matter when Yuan's already months, even years ahead of other players, it still doesn't make any sense why he would want to take a break so suddenly.

"Did something happen today? Is that why you're taking a break?" Yu Rou asked him. "It's okay to speak to me, brother."

"No, it has nothing to do with the game, honestly. I just want to take a break and prepare myself before I partake in the examination."

"Preparations for the examination... in the real world?" Yu Rou could not understand his intentions, but since Yuan insisted on taking a break, there was nothing she could do. After all, it was not as if she could force him to play the game.

"Okay. Then I'll leave you alone now. Goodnight, brother." Yu Rou closed the lights in the room before leaving Yuan alone.

Once he was alone, Yuan immediately began cultivating, and he would not stop for the rest of the night.

By the following morning, Yuan had managed to breakthrough once again, reaching fourth level Spirit Apprentice.

"Haaa... This is taking much longer than the game. If only there were monster cores in this world or things equivalent that would allow me to increase my cultivation faster..." Yuan sighed.

Sometime later, Yu Rou entered his room to clean his face and brush his teeth before feeding him breakfast.

After Yuan consumed all three bowls of soup, Yu Rou wiped his lips with a wet towel before leaving for school.

Once he was alone again, Yuan returned to cultivating. Even though the progress might be slow, at least he can make some progress.

Yuan repeated this process for the next two days, and besides eating and cultivating he was doing nothing else— not even sleeping.

By the time the Dragon Essence Temple began their disciple examination, Yuan had reached the fifth level Spirit Apprentice realm.

"Yu Rou, I am going back to Cultivation Online today. The Dragon Essence Temple should begin their disciple examination today, too," Yuan said to her after breakfast.

"Okay. Good luck, brother. Of course, I'm sure you'll pass the exam without any effort." Yu Rou chuckled.

And then she said, "Oh, I know you're already going to be in the spotlight, so try not to reveal your identity as Player Yuan, okay? You have no idea how many players are looking for you right now. If they learn of your identity, our lives will no longer be as peaceful."

"I understand..." Yuan responded in a nervous voice.

Sometime later, Yuan returned to the world of cultivation.

"Welcome back, Brother Yuan." Xiao Hua was the first to appear before him.

"I am back. The Dragon Essence Temple disciple examination should be today, right?" Yuan asked.

"That's right." Xiao Hua nodded, and then she turned to look towards the direction of the Dragon Essence Temple. "There's already a lot of people gathered."

"Then let's get going!"

However, Xiao Hua shook her head and said, "Brother Yuan, Xiao Hua will remain inside the necklace until you decide to leave the sect or need help. This way, Brother Yuan can experience the cultivation world the way it's meant to. If you ever need advice, Xiao Hua will speak to you using Divine Sense like the Vermilion Phoenix."

Yuan nodded and said, "It's going to feel lonely without having you by my side all the time, but I understand why you are doing this."

After Xiao Hua returned to the necklace, Yuan began running towards the Dragon Essence Temple.

'Oh, right... There will be a lot of people participating in this examination—both NPCs and Players alike. In order to keep my identity safe, I should at least hide my face.'

Thinking that, Yuan stopped moving and retrieved the Black Jade Mask and wore it on his face, hiding everything but his bright and innocent eyes.

"This should be good enough," Yuan nodded to himself before he continued running towards the Dragon Essence Temple.

Sometime later, Yuan arrived at the Dragon Essence Temple, and as he'd expected, there was already a sea of people gathered there.

'Wow... Is this what it feels like going to school on the first day?' Yuan wondered to himself as he followed the crowd.

Many minutes later, they arrived at this mountain range that had nothing but mountains and trees beside a large gate at the horizon that had a majestic sign with the words 'Dragon Essence Temple' on it.

'We are taking the examination here?' Yuan raised his eyebrows.

After waiting around for a few more minutes, a middle-aged man wearing colorful robes appeared before them by jumping on top of the gate.

"Welcome to the Dragon Essence Temple disciple examination! Before we begin the examination, we must verify whether or not you are actually qualified to be here!" The middle-aged man spoke to them in a loud and domineering voice.

"Below me is a transportation gate that will teleport you to the real examination halls. However, only those who have the Dragon Essence Temple Exam Token will be teleported to the examination hall. Everyone else will be teleported randomly to the mountain range behind me, and there are many powerful magical beasts that roam that area, so if you are thinking about sneaking into the disciple examination, I urge you to rethink that decision because we won't take responsibility for whatever happens to you afterward."

Chapter 99 - First Tes

"Now, if you are ready to partake in the Dragon Essence Temple disciple examination, step forth and enter the gate!"

After he finished speaking, the middle-aged man jumped down from the gate before walking into the gate as a demonstration, disappearing into the portal.

And immediately afterward, the people there began rushing towards the gate. Meanwhile, there were more than just a couple of people there who decided to remain standing still and not approach the gate, clearly hesitant to continue.

As for Yuan, he followed the mass and entered the gate.

A second after entering the gate, along with every person that entered the gate, Yuan was transported to this vast and empty grassland that stretched to the horizon. Furthermore, there was another gate that resembled the one they just entered a few miles away from their location.

"W-Where are we?"

The people there were puzzled as to why they were brought to this empty grassland. After all, what could they possibly do in this place that is related to the examination?

After waiting for a few minutes for everyone to gather, the middle-aged man with the colorful robes began to speak, "This will be your first examination. In this vast grassland that spans over 10,000 miles, there are 1,000 hidden jade slips, and only those who have a jade slip may advance to the next stage of the examination. You all have two days to advance to the

next test by entering the gate over there before you are automatically disqualified and kicked out of this place."

"Does anyone have any questions?"

The participants there immediately raised their hands.

"What kind of examination is this? I don't see how finding a needle in a haystack has anything to do with becoming a disciple of the Dragon Essence Temple!"

The middle-aged man turned to whoever just spoke and said, "This is an examination based on your luck—we are simply testing your fate—whether you are fated to become a disciple or not. Although you may not understand it, one's fortune and destiny play a huge role in the cultivation world, and without either of these, you will never achieve anything great in the cultivation world, and our Dragon Essence Temple has no use for someone like that."

"Senior, what exactly do you mean by 'hidden'? Are they buried underground or are they just placed around this grassland?" Another participant asked a few moments later.

The middle-aged man smiled at the participant's question and said, "There are 997 jade slips resting above the ground normally with three special jade slips buried within the ground. If any of you manages to find the jade slip buried within the ground, you will receive a very special reward at the end of the examination if you pass the examination, or you can exchange the jade slip to automatically become a disciple. However, if you do that, you will forfeit the reward. The choice is up to you."

After answering a few more questions, the middle-aged man said, "The first examination begins!"

Immediately after the middle-aged man ended his sentence, the thousands of people gathered there began spreading out in every direction and running around with their heads looking left and right without stopping.

Meanwhile, Yuan stood there with a calm expression on his face.

'This is not much different from when I had to pick Spirit Grass with Yu Rou. I should be able to find it with my Divine Sense,' Yuan thought to himself.

'Hm? Why's this young lad just standing there?' The middle-aged man turned to look at Yuan after noticing his odd behavior. However, when he saw the powerful aura subtly emitting from Yuan's body, he immediately gasped in shock.

'Fifth level Spirit Warrior?! Why the hell is someone like that participating in our disciple examination?! He could instantly qualify to become an Inner Disciple if he spoke to a sect elder!'

It was not just the middle-aged man who had noticed Yuan's powerful presence, as a few figures within the participants had also taken notice of him. Furthermore, the sect elders that were watching the disciple examination from somewhere within the Dragon Essence Temple with a treasure were all pondering to themselves why someone at his level would go through the trouble to participate in the examination meant for beginners or those without backgrounds.

In fact, there were even a few of them who thought Yuan could be a spy sent by another place.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan closed his eyes and began using his Divine Sense to search for the jade slips.

'Divine Sense?! Impossible! He's only a Spirit Warrior! How can he possibly use Divine Sense?! But that aura! This feeling! He's definitely using Divine Sense!'

The middle-aged man became even more surprised after realizing what Yuan was doing, nearly falling on his butt from shock.

Meanwhile, somewhere in the Dragon Essence Temple, a dozen sect elders gathered and watched the situation from a large bucket of water that

projected whatever was happening in the examination hall.

"What the heck?! Who is this person?! He can even use Divine Sense as a Spirit Warrior!"

"Whoever he is— his background must be immensely powerful! That's probably why he's hiding his identity!"

"What should we do? Should we just let him participate in the examination?"

"Let's continue watching to see what he's up to."

While many pairs of eyes watched Yuan's every movement, Yuan himself had already found six pieces of jade slip with his Divine Sense.

'It's too easy if I look for the normal jade slips. Let's try finding the ones buried in the ground for that special reward. I have two whole days, anyway.'

With that in mind, Yuan walked around the vast grassland with his Divine Sense activated.

After walking around for three hours with his Divine Sense constantly looking around, Yuan suddenly stopped moving.

"Oh? Is this it?"

Yuan retrieved his Starry Abyss and used it to dig a hole in the ground.

A few moments later, he grabbed the red-colored jade slip from the ground.

Meanwhile, the people watching him were speechless, as they didn't expect someone with Divine Sense to participate in their disciple examination.

'So much for luck and fate...' The middle-aged man sighed after seeing the red jade slip in Yuan's hands.

Chapter 100 - Second Tes

After obtaining one of the three special jade slips, Yuan proceeded to walk towards the gate.

However, the middle-aged man overseeing that examination suddenly approached Yuan and blocked his path.

"Congratulations on finding the first special jade slip, young man. I am Elder Long, an Outer Court Sect Elder for the Dragon Essence Temple. May I have your name?" The middle-aged man spoke to Yuan in a polite voice.

"Yuan," he responded.

"Daoist Yuan, huh? Anyway, since you have the special jade slip, allow me to explain a few more things to you. You can obtain a special jade slip in every test, and the more you gather, the better your reward will be towards the end. Furthermore, if you manage to obtain a special jade slip for every test, you'll get to enter the Dragon Temple for 24 hours."

"Dragon Temple? What is that?" Yuan asked.

"The Dragon Temple is a very special place that can only be accessed by the Sect Master of the Dragon Essence Temple, and once inside, you will have a limited time to search for and obtain as many treasures as you can in the given time. As for what kinds of treasures you can find inside... You will learn more about it if you actually manage to obtain access to that place."

Yuan nodded and said, "Okay, I will try my best."

"Good luck, Daoist Yuan."

Elder Long said to him before leaving him alone and returning to overseeing the other participants.

After Elder Long left, Yuan continued moving forward and entered the gate a few moments later, disappearing from the grassland.

Once Yuan left, Elder Long turned to look at the sky and said, "His name is Yuan! A prodigy who can use Divine Sense as a Spirit Warrior can't be a nobody!"

Meanwhile, a few of the sect elders watching the exam left the spectators' room and began trying to uncover Yuan's real background.

"This is the second examination?" Yuan looked around the area that resembled the wilderness.

"Congratulations on passing the first test. In order to pass the second exam, you must hunt magical beasts."

A young woman suddenly approached Yuan and said to him.

"Hunting magical beasts? Perfect!" Yuan said.

The young woman raised her eyebrows after seeing Yuan's enthusiasm. Normally, one would not react with excitement when they're told to hunt magical beasts but nervousness instead.

The young woman then said with a frown on her face, "Although there are Sect Elders scattered around this place to make sure there are as few incidents as possible, we cannot guarantee your safety, and there have been plenty of participants who died here."

"I see..." Yuan nodded, yet his voice did not sound worried at all.

"..."

The young woman was speechless. However, when she used her spiritual sense to look at Yuan's cultivation base, her eyes widened with shock.

"Fifth level Spirit Warrior?!" she exclaimed in a loud voice.

"Eh? Yes, I am at the fifth level Spirit Warrior. Is there something wrong with that?" Yuan asked her in an innocent voice.

"Yes... I mean... No...?"

The young woman did not know how to respond to Yuan's question. Although the examination did not forbid Spirit Warriors from participating in the examination, they have also never had a participant as powerful as Yuan before, as most people above the Spirit Apprentice realm would automatically be accepted into the Dragon Essence Temple without needing to pass the examination.

Furthermore, most of the magical beasts in this examination were only at the Spirit Apprentice level with only a few at the Spirit Warrior level. There was simply no way someone at the fifth level Spirit Warrior level would have trouble in this place!

After a moment of silence, the young woman cleared her throat before speaking, "Ahem! A-Anyway, in order to pass this test, you must hunt magical beasts to obtain points— 100 points to be exact. Depending on the level of the magical beast you defeat, you will gain a certain amount of points. For example, magical beasts at the first level Spirit Apprentice level will give you 1 point and a third level Spirit Apprentice magical beast will give you 3 points. As for the magical beasts above the Spirit Apprentice level, they will all give you 25 points. There will be a time limit of three days for this exam."

"Do you have any questions?"

Yuan nodded before asking, "What about the special jade slip? How do I obtain that here?"

"The special jade slip...?"

Yuan then showed her the red jade slip he obtained from the first test.

"Oh, that. It's been so long since someone tried to obtain it that I'd nearly forgotten about it."

"1,000 points. If you can obtain 1,000 points, you'll get the special jade slip," said the young woman.

"1,000 points... This might take longer than the previous test." Yuan mumbled.

After a moment of silence, Yuan asked the Sect Elder, "Senior, where can I find the most magical beasts at the Spirit Warrior level?"

"Uh... Over there..." The Sect Elder pointed towards the west.

"Thank you!" Yuan said to her before running towards the west.

"...Where on earth did such an oddball come from? Fifth level Spirit Warrior... He's already almost at my cultivation level, yet he's taking the examination?" The Sect Elder shook her head after Yuan left.

«+4 points»

A notification appeared after Yuan killed a magical beast at the fourth level Spirit Apprentice realm in a single hit with the Empyrean Overlord.

"Heavens, this is such a powerful sword! The Spirit Sword is nothing compared to this!" Yuan looked at the massive sword in his grasp that felt no heavier than a wooden stick with a mesmerizing gaze.

Even though the monster was only at the Spirit Apprentice level, he'd managed to kill it with a casual swing that barely had any force behind it, almost like slicing tofu with a sharp knife! There was simply no resistance from the magical beasts!

Chapter 101 - Third Tes

«+5 points»

«+6 points»

«+3 points»

«+7 points»

Every time Yuan swung his massive sword, a magical beast would inevitably succumb to death, and his points racked up extremely quickly, resembling the time at Pang City.

Meanwhile, the Sect Elder watching Yuan sweep through the magical beasts as though they were trash was shocked speechless.

'Which numbskull gave a fifth level Spirit Warrior the examination token? Whoever it was, he needs a damn beating! And I will be the first to volunteer for that!' The Sect Elder cursed inwardly as he counted the points Yuan had obtained.

Two hours later, Yuan had managed to collect a total of 300 points.

"Did that Senior give me the wrong directions? I haven't seen a single Spirit Warrior magical beast since I started hunting them..." Yuan sighed.

After running around aimlessly for another hour, Yuan finally encountered a magical beast at the Spirit Warrior level. However, because he immediately killed it a second later, it didn't feel any different from hunting Spirit Apprentice magical beasts.

'The fuck! He killed a Spirit Warrior magical beast in a single strike! And he even made it look so effortlessly!' The Sect Elder watching Yuan cried inwardly after seeing this.

'What is someone like him doing at the Dragon Essence Temple? Although we may be one of the top sects, there are other places stronger than us, such as the Heaven and Earth Palace! Surely, he would benefit more by going to those places!'

The Sect Elder could not understand Yuan's intentions for choosing their sect when there are much better options out there, and those sects would not refuse someone as ridiculously talented as him even in a million years, yet he decided to come to the Dragon Essence Temple, even going through the effort of participating in the disciple examination.

Meanwhile, Yuan continued to slay magical beasts for points without a care in the world.

After a few more hours, Yuan finally managed to amass a total of 1,000 points, becoming the first participant to reach 1,000 points in many decades.

'What else can one expect? It's like throwing a tiger into a chicken pen!' The Sect Elder watching Yuan wasn't even surprised that he'd obtained 1,000 points. In fact, he expected nothing less from Yuan!

A few moments later, the Sect Elder watching Yuan decided to approach him and said, "Congratulations, young man. You have managed to collect 1,000 points, being the first person in 69 years to have achieved this!" The Sect Elder congratulated him.

"Thank you. Do I get my special jade slip now?" Yuan asked.

"Of course. Here you go." The Sect Elder then handed to Yuan a blue-colored jade slip.

And then he continued, "The gate is to the north that way."

Once Yuan left the scene, the Sect Elder took a seat on the floor with an exhausted expression on his face.

"I have never felt so tired in my life, and I haven't even done anything significant. However, I am more mentally exhausted than physically, so..."

Sometime later, Yuan reached the gate to the next test. However, he didn't immediately enter it.

Instead, he logged off to cultivate until Yu Rou entered his room with dinner.

"How was the examination, brother?" Yu Rou asked him as she wiped his body.

"Was it difficult?"

"It's actually pretty easy. But I have only experienced two tests, so I cannot say anything for the rest of the exams. In fact, I don't even know how many exams I have to pass before I become a disciple," Yuan said.

"Is that so? Want to tell me about it?"

"Of course," Yuan said, and he proceeded to tell her about the first exam and then the second exam.

"Haha... You make it sound so easy, but I bet it's actually very difficult for the others." Yu Rou chuckled.

Sometime later, after dinner, Yu Rou returned to her own room whilst Yuan returned to the cultivation world to continue with the exam.

After entering the gate to the third test, Yuan found himself before a very large pond with silver-colored water and a silver tree towards the end of the pond. Furthermore, there were already over a hundred people waiting near the silver pond.

"What is this?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"Welcome to the third test." A young man wearing regular disciple robes suddenly greeted Yuan.

"Hello. What do I have to do for this test?" Yuan asked him.

"It's very simple. You just enter the pond and walk towards the silver tree. The further you go, the better the results. However, you only need to take 20 steps in order to pass this exam." The disciple explained to him.

"Twenty steps...?" Yuan became even more puzzled after the explanation. What kind of weird exam was this?

Seeing Yuan's puzzled eyes behind the black mask, the disciple continued, "This pond is no ordinary pond— it's a profound treasure that tests ones' talent, and the further you can go, the more talented you are."

"Normal Cultivators would only be able to take around 10 steps before they are unable to move forward. Meanwhile, talented Cultivators should have no problem taking over 20 steps. If you can take 50 steps, you are considered a peak Cultivation genius, but only one or two people would achieve that every ten years."

"I see..." Yuan nodded as he finally understood the meaning behind this test, and he asked a moment later, "What happens if one reaches the tree in the back?"

The disciple looked at Yuan with a dazed face before laughing out loud, "It takes 100 steps to reach the silver tree, but there has only been one person in our sect's history that has managed to reach the silver tree, and that person is the Dragon Essence Temple's Founder, who had passed away over a hundred thousand years ago."

"A hundred thousand years ago..." Yuan mumbled in a dazed voice.

"Oh, I have one more question. How many steps do I need to take to obtain the special jade slip from this test?" Yuan then asked.

"The special jade slip? That requires you to take 75 steps if I recall correctly." The disciple said.

"Okay, thank you," Yuan said before joining the other participants.

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Chapter 102 - Fifty Steps

After joining the other participants near the silver pond, Yuan watched as the participants walked on the silver water one by one.

The person currently taking this test was a young man who just took his 13th step towards the silver tree. However, this young man's face was soaked in sweat, looking as though he had just run a marathon or had been splashed in the face with a bucket of water.

"Ahhhh!"

The young man suddenly began shouting while lifting his leg slowly, looking as though he was really struggling to take another step.

Splash!

The young man fell a few seconds later, falling directly on top of the silver water without submerging into the water like one would have expected.

"13 steps... failed." The Sect Elder standing next to the silver pond said after the young man fell down.

The Sect Elder then waved his sleeves, using his spiritual energy to pull the participant back to where the other participants were gathered before speaking out loud, "Next!"

A moment later, a young lady stepped forward and bowed to the Sect Elder before turning to stare at the silver pond and the tree.

After taking a deep breath, she took her first step into the silver liquid and towards the silver tree.

Tap... Tap... Tap...

The silver water rippled with every step the young lady took.

A few moments later, the young lady took her 19th step.

On her twentieth step, although she struggled a little bit, she still managed to take the 20th step, passing the exam. However, the young lady did not stop despite already passing the exam and continued to push herself for a few more steps.

In the end, the young lady managed to achieve 23 steps for the exam.

"You have passed. You may enter the gate now and proceed to your final test." The Sect Elder said to the young lady, who bowed to him before leaving the test area.

'So there is only one more test after this one, huh. I wonder what kind of test it is...' Yuan pondered to himself as he continued to watch the participants challenge the test one by one.

About half an hour later, a young lady with long black hair and a pair of sharp eyes stepped forward to challenge the silver water. However, unlike the previous participants, this young lady attracted the attention of every individual there with her beauty and the domineering aura around her.

"It's finally Fairy Min's turn! I wonder how many steps the genius of the Min Family is going to take!"

"Hahaha, of course, she's going to take 50 steps easily!"

"Good luck, Fairy Min!"

The participants there spoke and cheered for her as though they were very familiar with this beautiful lady's identity, and even the Sect Elder foreseeing the test gave her an approving nod.

A few moments later, once the atmosphere calmed down and the participants were quiet, the young lady known as Fairy Min took her first

step into the silver pond.

One step, two steps, three steps.

Fairy Min easily traveled over ten steps without any effort and with her every movement filled with confidence and arrogance.

Eleven steps, twelve steps, thirteen steps.

Fairy Min took her twentieth step as effortlessly as she did the previous ten without breaking a single sweat on her body.

"As expected of Fairy Min! She might even reach 75 steps at this rate!"

The other participants were incredibly excited for Fairy Min, feeling as though they were in her shoes.

A few more moments later, Fairy Min took her thirtieth step, surpassing every participant that had taken this test thus far.

A few more moments later, she took her fortieth step.

However, after taking her fortieth step, Fairy Min did not immediately take her next step and instead stood still for a minute to catch her breath.

Almost a minute later, Fairy Min finally challenged the silver pond with her 41st step.

Splash!

A powerful ripple appeared in the pond as Fairy Min took her 41st step.

After her 41st step, Fairy Min stopped for another minute before taking the next step, and she would continue this until she took her 47th step.

"Haaa... haaa... haaa..." Fairy Min panted heavily with sweat dripping down her face as she took her 48th step.

Splash!

Another ripple appeared in the silver pond after she took her 48th step.

After resting for a minute, Fairy Min attempted her 49th step.

"Ha!"

Fairy Min suddenly shouted out loud as she took her 49th step, and without taking another break, she went straight for the 50th step.

Boom!

The entire silver pond trembled after Fairy Min took her 50th step.

Fairy Min wanted to take another step, but alas, she knew that her body would not be able to endure another step, so she turned around and returned to the Sect Elder.

"Congratulations, Min Li from the Min Family— you are the first person in the last 7 years to have walked 50 steps for this test." The Sect Elder congratulated her upon her return.

"Thank you, Senior..." Min Li nodded her head, yet she appeared to be disappointed by her results.

"You may proceed onto the final test." The Sect Elder then said to her.

Min Li nodded, and she walked to the gate. However, she stopped walking after she reached the front of the gate and turned around to stare in the direction of the other participants with a profound gaze, or more specifically, she was staring at the figure wearing a black jade mask, who was emitting a profound and mysterious aura.

After staring at Yuan for a moment, she turned around and stepped into the gate, disappearing from the test area.

Once Min Li left the scene, the other participants returned to being silent, and the test continued as usual.

Many minutes later, it was finally Yuan's turn, and he stepped forward.

"Why is he wearing a mask? What an odd fellow." The participants mumbled to themselves after seeing Yuan's appearance.

However, when the Sect Elder saw Yuan, his eyes widened in shock like the other Sect Elders.

'Fifth level Spirit Warrior!' he cried inwardly.

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Chapter 103 - The Final Step

'What the hell is a Cultivator at the fifth level Spirit Warrior realm doing here?! Even Min Li from the Min Family was only at the peak of the Spirit Apprentice realm!' The Sect Elder was greatly baffled by Yuan's unusual and overwhelming presence in the exam.

And since most of the other participants there were between the third level and seventh level Spirit Apprentice realm, they weren't even able to see Yuan's real cultivation base.

"Just to confirm, I just have to walk to that silver tree, correct?" Yuan asked the Sect Elder, snapping him out of his daze.

"T-That's correct! As long as you can take 20 steps, you will pass this exam."

Yuan nodded his head, and he proceeded to take his first step into the silver pond.

'What kind of results will he have? Although he's already at the fifth level Spirit Warrior realm, this test doesn't care for one's achievements, only their raw talents!' The Sect Elder watched Yuan with interest and curiosity, even a little bit of excitement, wondering what kind of results he would show them.

Meanwhile, Yuan just took his first step into the silver pond.

'This feels like I am walking on a mattress filled with water or something like that...' Yuan thought to himself as his feet touched the silver liquid that supported his weight.

After taking his first step, Yuan took his second step, then a third, and then a fourth— until he took his 20th step.

"Who is that man? He managed to take 20 steps effortlessly like Fairy Min!"

"He's blocking his face so we can't tell!"

The participants were surprised to see a nobody casually taking 20 steps as though he was taking a stroll in the park.

Meanwhile, Yuan continued walking towards the silver tree with a calm expression on his face behind the mask.

21... 22... 23...

28... 29... 30...

After taking his thirtieth step, Yuan did not stop and continued approaching the silver tree.

"Heavens! He's already taking his 35th step! And he did it without taking a single break!"

"Could this man be another genius at Fairy Min's level?!"

"Haha, I doubt it. Fairy Min is a real Cultivation genius! Although 15 steps may appear very little, the gap is actually immense— like heaven and earth!"

"I am willing to bet that he'll stop before 40 steps!"

"I bet that he'll reach 45 steps at most!"

While the participants began betting with each other for the results, Yuan continued walking towards the silver tree.

A few moments later, Yuan reached 45 steps without feeling any resistance or breaking a sweat.

After taking a few more steps, Yuan achieved 50 steps, rivaling Fairy Min's results.

"Good lord! First, we have Fairy Min who became the first person to achieve 50 steps in the last 7 years, now we have this mysterious man who also achieved 50 steps on the same day! To have two people achieving 50 steps so close to each other— this is unprecedented!"

However, as the participants there trembled in excitement, Yuan continued to move forward.

"He's still going!"

51...52...53...54...55...

Boom!

The silver pond trembled the moment Yuan took his 60th step.

'I still don't feel any different... Is there something wrong?' Yuan raised his eyebrows when nothing happened after taking 60 steps whilst the other participants began struggling much sooner.

However, since he didn't feel anything, Yuan continued to walk.

A few moments later, he took his 75th step, shocking the participants and the Sect Elder.

"75 steps! He managed to take 75 steps! This man is a real prodigy!"

The participants stared at Yuan with gawking expressions.

"One thousand years... It's been over 1,000 years since someone has taken 75 steps in the Pond of Evaluation..." The Sect Elder mumbled in a dazed voice.

However, Yuan was not done yet, as he still felt no resistance or challenge from the silver ponde, almost like the silver pond was purposefully going

easy on him, and after taking the 75th step, he continued moving towards the silver tree towards the end.

"He's going for the silver tree! He might actually do it!"

"75 steps is already impressive enough! Does he really think he can take 100 steps and reach the silver tree that has only been achieved by one person in history—the founder of the Dragon Essence Temple?!"

"He only has 25 steps left to reach the silver tree, but every single step will feel as though he's trying to leap over an entire sea, and it will only grow increasingly more difficult as he gets closer to the tree!"

"I am willing to bet that he won't make it past 90 steps!"

"I bet 100 gold he'll stop at 80 steps!"

"50 gold he'll make it past 90 steps!"

"I will bet 10 gold he'll actually make it to the silver tree!"

While the participants began another gambling session on whether the results, Yuan continued to approach the silver tree with slow but calm steps, still feeling no pressure whatsoever.

'This is probably the easiest test in this exam...' Yuan thought to himself as he took his 90th step.

"90 steps! He only has 10 more to go before he becomes the second person in history to reach the silver tree!"

Everybody there watched with a nervous feeling in their guts, feeling as though they were in Yuan's shoes.

91 steps... 92 steps... 93 steps...

Every single step Yuan took after the 90th step would cause the entire place to tremble, and on his 95th step, the silver tree at the end of the pond began glowing brightly.

"W-What is happening?!" The Sect Elder took a few steps back from shock, his gaze filled with disbelief.

However, Yuan ignored the glowing tree and continued to walk.

96...97...98 steps!

On Yuan's 98th step, the silver tree began cracking with a subtle golden light coming from within the cracks.

After Yuan took his 99th step, the cracks grew even larger, and the entire tree was filled with these cracks.

"The final step..." Yuan mumbled as he took his 100th step, leaving the silver water and stepping onto the land that hosted the silver tree.

Boom!

The moment Yuan finished all 100 steps, the silver tree suddenly exploded, transforming into a golden tree, baffling everyone in the test room!

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Chapter 104 - Talent That Rivals Their Founder

"H-H-He really did it! He really managed to take 100 steps and reach the silver tree!"

The Sect Elders watching the examination from afar were all shocked speechless by Yuan's flawless performance.

"What happened to the silver tree, though? Why did it turn golden? This didn't happen before even when the founder achieved 100 steps— at least it was not recorded!"

"Forget about the tree! We have another prodigy who rivals our founder in terms of talents! We must let the Sect Master and the Grand Elders know about this as soon as possible! We cannot let such a talent leave our grasp!"

The Sect Elders there then scrambled outside to look for the Sect Master and Grand Elders.

Meanwhile, back at the examination hall, after crossing the silver pond and reaching the silver tree that had suddenly turned into a golden tree, Yuan calmly walked back to the other participants before approaching the Sect Elder.

"I only need to take 75 steps to receive the special jade slip, correct?" Yuan asked the Sect Elder, not even caring about his achievement of 100 steps that put him on the same level as their founder.

"T-T-That's correct..." The Sect Elder nearly forgot how to speak after experiencing this shocking event.

After panicking for a few moments, the Sect Elder finally managed to retrieve a white-colored jade slip and handed it to Yuan with trembling hands.

"H-Here you go..." The Sect Elder lowered his body and offered the special jade slip to Yuan, acting almost like a servant before his lord.

"Thank you," Yuan accepted the white-colored jade slip before tossing it into his spatial ring with the rest of the special jade slips.

After storing away the white-colored jade slip, Yuan turned to the gate and began walking towards it.

"W-Wait a second! Where are you going?" The Sect Elder suddenly stopped him.

"Huh? Didn't I pass this test?" Yuan responded in a dumbfounded voice. Since he passed this test, he was obviously going to the next test.

"You're going to take the next test? That won't be necessary." The Sect Elder shook his head and continued, "You are the only person besides the Founder of the Dragon Essence Temple to have achieved 100 steps in this place, meaning your talents rival our Founder. There's no longer any need for you to participate in the next test because you will be accepted into the sect regardless of the results."

"I don't need to take the next test...?" Yuan raised his eyebrows. How else is he going to obtain the final special jade slip and enter the Dragon Temple?

After a moment of silence, Yuan spoke, "Even if I pass now, I would still like to participate in the final test. After all, I have already come this far. It wouldn't feel good if I stopped here without finishing it. Furthermore, I am doing this mostly for the experience, and I don't want to lose that feeling."

"Doing this for the experience...?" The Sect Elder looked at Yuan with a surprised expression on his face.

However, after pondering for a moment, he found sense in Yuan's words. After all, nobody at the fifth level Spirit Warrior realm would willingly waste their time in this place unless they were doing it for another purpose.

'Perhaps he's a Young Master from a very powerful family that's currently on a journey for training? That would make sense as to why he has to hide his identity and why he's participating in this disciple examination.' The Sect Elder thought to himself.

"If you insist on continuing with the examination, go ahead. I won't stop you if that's what you really want. Just remember that no matter the results, you'll still be qualified to become a disciple at our Dragon Essence Temple." The Sect Elder reminded Yuan before letting him go.

"Thank you," Yuan nodded his head, and he proceeded onto the next test shortly later.

Meanwhile, somewhere within the Dragon Essence Temple, the Sect Master and the Grand Elders gathered at the spectators' room, where the other Sect Elders have been watching the disciple examination.

"Are you sure? That someone from the examination managed to cross the Pond of Evaluation and achieve 100 steps, even making the silver tree turn golden?" The Sect Master of the Dragon Essence Temple, Long Yijun, asked the Sect Elders there with a serious expression on his face.

"Take a look for yourself, Sect Master. The golden tree."

The Sect Elders pointed at the treasure that projected the area for the third exam, and there was a golden tree clearly in the projection.

"Hmm..." Long Yijun became silent and began pondering with a deep frown on his face.

"This participant... What's his name?"

An old man with short white hair and a short beard suddenly asked.

The Sect Elders turned to look at the Grand Elder who just spoke, and one of them said, "He called himself 'Yuan', but we're not sure whether that's his surname or given name. Furthermore, he's already at the fifth level Spirit Warrior realm."

"Huh? His name is Yuan? And he's a fifth level Spirit Warrior?" The old man looked at the Sect Elders with a dazed face.

"Is there something wrong, Elder Xuan?" Long Yijun noticed his odd reaction and asked him.

After a moment of silence, Elder Xuan suddenly burst out laughing for a good minute before speaking, "There's no need to investigate this individual. I know him."

"What? You know this man?"

Everybody in the room looked at him with a surprised look on their faces.

Elder Xuan nodded and said, "Yes, he's my granddaughter— Xuan Wuhan's friend. She sent me a message not long ago about someone very talented and by the name of Yuan who might visit our Dragon Essence Temple in the future and to treat him well."

"Core Disciple Xuan's friend?"

The Sect Elders didn't know whether to laugh or cry after hearing this news, as they had spent the entire day scrambling their heads trying to figure out Yuan's identity and whether or not he was a spy only to find out that he was related to the Xuan Family.

Chapter 105 - The Last Tes

"Now that we know this cultivation prodigy's identity, what should we do, Sect Master?" One of the sect elders suddenly asked him.

"What do you think, Elder Xuan?" Long Yijun turned to look at him for advice. "Since he's technically yours, what do you want to do with him?"

Elder Xuan shrugged and said, "How am I supposed to know? I don't even know his intentions for coming here! We can decide where to go once I have a little conversation with this young man."

And then he continued, "In the meantime, you should prepare to open the Dragon Temple, Sect Leader. I have a good feeling this young lad will obtain the last special jade slip from the final test and collect all of them, becoming the first one to do so in 10,000 years."

"The Dragon Temple, huh? It's been such a long time since someone qualified to enter that place." Long Yijun smiled, and he continued, "Even if this young man doesn't manage to obtain the last special jade slip, I'll still let him enter the Dragon Temple, as that is most likely what our Founder would want to happen if he were still here today."

After a moment of silence, Long Yijun suddenly said, "Although this might be near impossible and a very difficult task to achieve, I want everything that is related to the young man named Yuan to be hidden from the public. I don't want the other sects to know about his existence for now, but when they do, it'll be a pleasant surprise for them."

"A pleasant surprise...? Are you thinking about letting him participate in the Mystic Realm next month?" Elder Xuan looked at Long Yijun with a surprised look on his face. "He'll only be a disciple for a month at that time

whilst the other disciples participating will all be Core Disciples. I cannot imagine the Core Disciples being very happy about a nobody who just joined the sect recently taking up one of their spots so suddenly when they are working themselves to the bone to obtain a spot, and there are very few spots available, which makes this situation even more sensitive."

"So what if the Core Disciples will be unhappy? If they are unhappy, they can go ahead and try to achieve 100 steps in the Pond of Evaluation! Even if they complain, the cultivation world favors those with talent, so they have no right to complain unless they are more talented than him!" Long Yijun spoke in a stern voice.

The sect elders in the room exchanged looks with each other. While they do not reject having someone as talented as Yuan take up a slot for the Mystic Realm, they don't know whether they should or should not let their disciples know about this, as their disciples were also Core Disciples trying to obtain a slot for the Mystic Realm.

Long Yijun noticed the perplexed expressions on the sect elders' faces, and he spoke, "Even if they are your disciples, it's best to leave them in the dark for now, as it might affect their cultivation negatively. The Dragon Essence Sect was only given 3 slots for the Mystic Realm, and with Yuan taking one of these slots, only two other Core Disciples will participate in the Mystic Realm. Though, you can tell them that we have already given one of the slots to a disciple— just not his identity."

"Yes, Sect Master." The sect elders acknowledged his orders.

"Now, let's see how this cultivation genius will do in the final test. Will he continue to surprise us, or will he do the opposite?"

Long Yijun and the other sect elders proceeded to spectate Yuan with the treasure.

Meanwhile, Yuan had just walked through the gate and entered the area for the final test; it was a large but empty room with a tall stone tablet located a few meters away in the center of the room.

The stone tablet resembled the stone tablets he saw in the Flying Sword Sect that were used to rank the disciples, but there were no names on this one— only complex symbols that somewhat looked like words.

"Congratulations on passing the previous three exams and reaching the final exam." A young woman with a very pretty face that had been waiting in the room said to Yuan after noticing his presence.

"This is the final test? Where are the other participants?" Yuan asked when he couldn't see anybody else there.

"The final exam is a bit special and requires absolute peace and concentration, so everybody will have their own room for the rest of the test," said the young woman.

"My name's Xue Jiye, and I will be overseeing this test."

"Before we begin, allow me to explain to you how this exam works and what you need to do in order to pass it."

Xue Jiye then pointed towards the tall stone tablet and said, "That stone tablet contains many cultivation techniques from our Dragon Essence Temple, and your goal is to study it and try to comprehend whatever technique it shows you. As for the technique it will be showing you, it will change depending on your test results from the previous exams. Therefore, the better your results from the previous exams, the more powerful and unique the cultivation technique the stone tablet will show you."

"As for the condition to pass this exam, you'll need to understand at least 10% of the cultivation technique. Do you have any questions?" Xue Jiye ended her sentence with a question.

"I need to comprehend 10% in order to pass, huh? What about the special jade slip? How much of the cultivation technique do I have to comprehend in order to obtain the special jade slip?" Yuan asked.

"The special jade slip...?" Xue Jiye raised her eyebrows. This is her first time being asked about the special jade slip since she first started

overseeing the participants, and it has been two years since then.

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Chapter 106 - Tablet Of Comprehension

After a moment of silence, Xue Jiye responded to Yuan's question regarding the special jade slip, "In order to obtain the special jade slip, you must comprehend at least 70 percent of the cultivation technique. Furthermore, you have only 7 days to study the stone tablet."

"Of course, the better your results, the better cultivation technique you'll get to learn, but that also means you'll need much longer to understand the technique, as stronger cultivation techniques are more often than not more complex and profound. However, no matter what cultivation technique the stone tablet gives you, the requirements are the same."

"I understand," Yuan nodded.

"Good. Do you have any more questions? If you do not, you may begin the test. The moment the Tablet of Comprehension reveals your cultivation technique is the moment your timer begins." she asked him.

"How do I know how much of the cultivation technique I have comprehended in the end?" Yuan asked her.

"The Tablet of Comprehension will let us know the results by the light it emits. A white glow means you have comprehended 10 percent of the cultivation technique which is required for you to pass this test. A green glow means you have understood 25 percent of the technique. It will glow an azure-colored light past 50 percent and a red light at 70 percent. At 80 percent, the stone tablet will emit a black light, and 90 percent will emit a golden light."

"What about 100 percent?" Yuan asked her out of curiosity.

"100 percent? That has never happened before so I don't know. In fact, nobody knows what will happen— not even the Founder who only managed to comprehend 90 percent in seven days." Xue Jiye shook her head.

Sometime later, Yuan walked to the tall stone tablet and stood before it.

"It's assessing your results and picking the perfect technique for you so give it a few minutes," Xue Jiye said to him as she pulled out a chair from her spatial ring before sitting down and watching him with a nonchalant expression on her face.

'Hm? Wait a second... This guy... This guy is a fifth level Spirit Warrior?! His cultivation is even higher than mine— two levels higher!' Xue Jiye was shocked when she realized Yuan's cultivation base.

'Just how old is this guy? His voice sounded very young— even younger than me!' Xue Jiye cried inwardly.

Meanwhile, in the spectators' room, the sect elders there started to gamble with each other.

"I am betting 100 contribution points that he'll achieve 50 percent understanding in 7 days!"

"I will bet 50 contribution points that he will reach 70 percent!"

"Since you guys are favoring him so much, I shall do the opposite! 100 contribution points that he'll reach less than 50 percent!"

"One thousand contribution points that he'll reach 90 percent." Long Yijun suddenly joined the fun, dumbfounding the sect elders.

"1,000 contribution points? That's ten years' worth of contribution points!" The sect elders exclaimed.

"How about you, Elder Xuan? Wanna make a bet? Whoever guesses correctly will obtain all contribution points placed in this bet."

"Hmm..." Elder Xuan looked at Yuan's figure from the treasure for a moment before speaking, "Then I shall bid 500 contribution points that he'll be the first person in history to reach 100 percent understanding."

"What? 100 percent?"

Everybody in the room looked at him with wide eyes.

"Aren't you giving him too much credit, Elder Xuan? Although his talent is definitely on par with the Founder's talent, even the Founder could only reach 90 percent after 7 days. Furthermore, because of his excellent results from the previous tests, one can only imagine what kind of technique he'll get, but one thing is for sure, and that is the technique won't be a weak one."

Long Yijun also chimed in, "I agree with Elder Xin. With his results, he'll get to learn at least an Earth-grade if not a Heaven-grade cultivation technique from the Tablet of Comprehension. I don't know about you, but I have never seen or heard of anyone that can fully comprehend an Earth-grade technique within 7 days, much less a Heaven-grade."

"Well, it wouldn't be a gamble if I don't go against the odds, right?" Elder Xuan laughed.

"Anyway, what is the most powerful cultivation technique the Tablet of Comprehension can reveal? The highest grade I have seen so far is at the Earth-grade, which happened 300 years ago."

Hearing Elder Xuan's question, Long Yijun said, "According to the Dragon Essence Temple's record, since the sect's founding, there have only been three people who received a cultivation technique above the Earth-grade from the stone tablet, and they were all at the Heaven-grade."

"However, as for the Founder... Although nobody knows what kind of technique he'd received, it was rumored to be a Divine-grade technique."

"A Divine-grade technique, huh?" Elder Xuan mumbled with a profound expression on his face.

Meanwhile, Yuan stood before the Tablet of Comprehension without moving a muscle, patiently waiting for it to reveal his cultivation technique.

About ten minutes later, Yuan's eyebrows suddenly twitched, as he could see lines that became symbols appearing on the Tablet of Comprehension.

"The Tablet of Comprehension has picked your cultivation technique! Your time starts now! Remember, you only have 7 days to comprehend as much of the technique as you can!" Xue Jiye said to him after seeing this.

Yuan immediately sat down in the lotus position and proceeded to stare at the stone tablet with an intensive gaze, looking as though he was trying to stare a hole in the stone tablet.

A few more minutes later, the symbols stopped appearing on the stone tablet.

Although he couldn't understand the symbols at first, after staring at the stone tablet for a few minutes, the symbols actually began moving and formed a picture! However, only Yuan was able to see this change on the stone tablet, whilst Xue Jiye and the others could only see a wall of still symbols!

"Dragon's Gaze?" Yuan suddenly mumbled these two words after staring at the picture that resembled an eyeball for many minutes with a seemingly mesmerized look on his face.

At the same moment Yuan learned of the technique's name, the stone tablet emitted a white glow, shocking Xue Jiye, and the others.

'Impossible! Only fifteen minutes have passed since he sat down!' Xue Jiye immediately stood up from shock after seeing this white glow, indicating that Yuan has already understood 10 percent of the technique!

Chapter 107 - Dragon's Gaze

Chapter 107 - Dragon's Gaze

"What! How is that possible?! Am I just seeing things or is the Tablet of Comprehension emitting a white glow already?! It hasn't even been half an hour since he sat down!"

The sect elders inside the spectators' room quickly became clamorous after seeing the Tablet of Comprehension glowing.

"This young man..." Long Yijun stared at the glowing stone tablet with a dazed look on his face.

"This Yuan is the definition of a true cultivation genius," Elder Xuan said with a smile on his face.

Meanwhile, inside the examination room, Xue Jiye stood there with a bewildered expression on her beautiful face, looking like she'd just seen a ghost.

'Impossible! How did he comprehend 10 percent of the technique already?! Even if it's a weak cultivation technique, he shouldn't be able to learn it so quickly!' she cried inwardly.

As for Yuan, he continued to stare at the symbols that formed an eyeball—glaring back at it with a piercing gaze.

The eyeball on the stone tablet grew more realistic and lively the longer Yuan stared at it, almost as though it was coming to life, and after glaring at it for an hour, Yuan could see colors appearing on the stone tablet and coloring the large eyeball.

Once the entire eyeball was colored in a golden and amber color, the Tablet of Comprehension began emitting a green light, indicating that Yuan had

comprehended at least 25 percent of the cultivation technique.

'My god! He's already at 25 percent comprehension!' Xue Jiye quickly covered her mouth when she suddenly felt the urge to scream out loud.

"25 percent! He's already at 25 percent!"

As for the people watching from the spectators' room, without needing to worry about interrupting Yuan's concentration, they shouted at the top of their lungs from excitement.

"Hahaha! At this rate, he might really comprehend the entire cultivation technique!" Elder Xuan laughed out loud, and he continued, "And he might even do it in less than 7 days!"

"Hmm..." Long Yijun remained silent and continued to stare at Yuan with a profound gaze.

Another two hours later, the eyeball on the stone tablet changed for Yuan again, and this time, the eyeball appeared to be emerging from the stone tablet!

Yuan was startled when he saw this change, but he didn't look away, as something about the eyeball kept his gaze attached, almost mesmerized.

And although the eyeball looked incredibly realistic, if one looked closely, they would not be able to sense any life in it, so it felt no different from looking at a realistic art— a masterpiece.

However, as Yuan continued to stare into this eyeball for another hour, he began to feel a profound pressure coming from it. Although it was only very slightly and barely noticeable at first, the longer he stared at it, the stronger the pressure became until it felt like he was being looked down upon by some superior entity, almost like a God looking at mortals from the Heavens.

However, despite this intense pressure, Yuan did not back down and challenged the gaze.

Boom!

After staring at the eyeball for some time, the eyeball suddenly flickered with a golden light, and Yuan found himself floating in the middle of the void and surrounded by stars the next second with Xue Jiye and the stone tablet nowhere to be seen, almost like he'd been teleported to the outer space.

"What the?" Yuan looked around with a puzzled expression on his face.

A few moments later, something caught his attention, causing him to turn around.

"?!?!?!"

When Yuan turned around and saw the massive creature flying behind him, his hair stood up straight like a cat when frightened or feeling threatened.

'Is this... a dragon?!' Yuan cried inwardly as he recognized the shape of this creature from movies when he was a kid.

However, this dragon was much larger than he remembered. It had large golden eyes the size of an entire planet and a massive body that stretched to the horizon countless miles into the distance.

Meanwhile, in the examination room, Xue Jiye noticed that Yuan had suddenly closed his eyes, seemingly asleep.

Furthermore, the stone tablet was no longer glowing a green light, and it had once again changed colors.

'Azure-colored light! He's comprehended 50 percent of the technique!' Xue Jiye cried inwardly after seeing this change, falling down onto the chair behind her.

In the spectators' room, the sect elders were no longer making noises. Instead, they silently stared at Yuan with a serious expression on their faces, pondering to themselves whether Yuan will really be able to comprehend

100 percent of the technique within 7 days, as it was looking increasingly likely that he would every time the stone tablet changed colors.

'It's only been 6 hours since he started studying the technique given by the Tablet of Comprehension and he has already managed to comprehend over half of the entire technique. At this rate, he'll really become the first person in history to achieve 100 percent comprehension, and he might do it in a single freaking day!' Long Yijun thought to himself.

'Where on earth did you find such a monster, my dear granddaughter?' Elder Xuan showed a bittersweet smile on his face.

Meanwhile, back in Yuan's mind where the dragon existed, even though he was like a speck of dust compared to the dragon, Yuan continued to stare back at the massive dragon despite its terrifying presence and incomprehensible size.

"What is your name, human?"

The dragon suddenly spoke to him.

"Oh? You can speak?" Yuan was pleasantly surprised by this, and he continued, "My name is Yuan."

"Yuan... You are the second person to have learned my Dragon's Gaze from the Tablet of Comprehension with the first one being a man named Long Chen. However, his comprehension abilities pale in comparison to yours, as it took him over three days to reach this far whilst it took you only a few hours, and he was frozen from shock when he first saw me." The dragon spoke in a deep and profound voice that caused the stars in the surroundings to tremble.

Chapter 108 - Star

"Are you... Are you real?" Yuan suddenly asked the dragon.

"No, I am a mere illusion created by the Tablet of Comprehension in this world. However, that is not to say I do not exist, as this is an illusion of my real-self. If you manage to reach the upper heavens then perhaps you will get to see the real me. And when that happens, don't think you'll be able to stand there as calmly as you are now." The Dragon spoke in an arrogant voice, sounding as though Yuan had somehow hurt its pride by not cowering in fear from its immense presence like any norm human should.

"Anyway, enough yapping, human. This great one shall demonstrate to you the power of Dragon's Gaze." The Dragon turned to look at the large planet in the distance and continued, "Do you see that star? Before the Dragon's Gaze, it is no different than a little rock..."

The Dragon's golden eyes suddenly flickered with a profound light before shooting out an invisible beam that flew straight at the planet in the distance.

A second later— BOOM!

The entire planet that was 10 times larger than Earth exploded into countless fragments before disappearing into the darkness, and the shockwave created by the explosion was powerful enough to send Yuan flying tens of miles backward. Of course, before the Dragon's incomprehensible size, it appeared as though Yuan never moved at all.

"..." Yuan witnessed this mind-blowing scene with his jaw dropped and his eyes wide open from shock, as he has never seen anything this dramatic before.

"That is the power of Dragon's Gaze at its maximum potential. In the beginning, you'll only be able to scare a few people with it, but once you understand the technique more, you'll be able to kill your enemies with a mere gaze!" The Dragon spoke afterward.

"Killing people with just my gazes? That sounds incredibly powerful but also extremely dangerous at the same time..." Yuan mumbled in a dazed voice.

"Anyway, can you do that again? I will need to see it a few more times before I can learn it," Yuan then said to the Dragon with an innocent expression on his face.

"A few times? Hahahaha!"

The Dragon suddenly exploded with laughter, causing the entire starry sky to tremble, and Yuan felt his internal organs dancing around viciously. However, for some odd reason, it didn't hurt him at all.

Once the Dragon stopped laughing a few moments later, it spoke in a serious voice, "Although your comprehension ability may be impressive, don't overestimate yourself, you mere human! The previous human had to watch the technique for hundreds of thousands of times before he could even begin to understand it! And only after watching for a few million more times did he finally understand the technique enough to use it!"

"A few million? But he only had seven days to study the technique, right? There's no way he could've watched the technique so many times in such a short time!" Yuan expressed his doubts.

"We are currently inside your mind, so time flows differently in here. You can stay in here for a few years if you wish and only a few hours will have passed in the outside world!" The Dragon said.

"What? I can study the technique for a few years while I am here?" Yuan mumbled in a dazed voice.

"Yes. However, your spirit and soul must also be strong enough to endure it because the longer you stay in here the more exhausting it will be for your body and mind, and you are only a Spirit Warrior whilst the previous human was already a Spirit Grandmaster when he came here."

"At your level, you will be able to remain inside this space for a few weeks at most, which is only enough to witness a few thousand Dragon's Gaze."

"A few thousand, huh? That should be more than enough," Yuan nodded with a calm expression on his face.

"..."

The Dragon stared at Yuan with its massive eyes narrowed after hearing his words. After a moment of silence, it spoke, "Since you are so confident that you can learn my Dragon's Gaze so easily, how about a little bet with me, human?"

"A bet? But aren't you only an illusion?" Yuan said.

"I may be an illusion but I still have some powers in here. Although I may not be able to physically help you, there are other things I can do here." The Dragon said.

And it continued, "As for the bet... If you can learn my Dragon's Gaze before I demonstrate it a total of 10,000 times, I will consider it your win, and I shall give you something very special."

"If you lose, well, there's really nothing you can do for me in here so you won't lose anything for losing the bet. Therefore, you can only gain something from this bet. How about it?"

Since there was nothing to lose, Yuan nodded. "Okay, let's do it."

"Good! Then watch closely, because I will be demonstrating my Dragon's Gaze without stopping now!"

The Dragon then turned to look at another planet in the distance that had suddenly appeared out of thin air before using the Dragon's Gaze once

again, obliterating the planet almost instantly.

Whoosh! Yuan was pushed back a few miles again after the explosion, yet he did not blink and stared with an intensive gaze as the Dragon continued destroying planets one at a time.

Boom! Boom! Boom!

The Dragon obliterated a dozen stars in just a few minutes, taking breaks only for a few breaths before its eyes shot out another star-destroying beam, and Yuan witnessed each and every single planet being obliterated without blinking his eyes.

Very quickly a couple of days have passed inside his mind, and Yuan has witnessed the Dragon's Gaze almost a thousand times.

Meanwhile, on the outside, the Tablet of Comprehension changed colors once again after a few hours of silence, turning bright red this time, shocking Xue Jiye and those in the spectators' room even more.

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Chapter 109 - State Of Enlightenment

"A red light! He's comprehended the technique 70 percent now! And it's been only a few hours since he comprehended 50 percent! Just how ridiculously talented is this guy?! He puts 'fast learners' to shame with his learning speed!" Xue Jiye could no longer contain her voice and mumbled in a shocked voice.

'I wonder what it looks like in the spectators' room right now... How are the sect elders reacting to this young man?' Xue Jiye pondered to herself.

Meanwhile, in the spectators' room, everybody there turned to look at Elder Xuan with a profound expression on their faces, thinking to themselves how Elder Xuan will most likely win this gamble and obtain 20 years' worth of contribution points in a single bet.

Back inside Yuan's mind, he continued watching the Dragon obliterate stars every few breaths until he could see the scene even if he closed his eyes and stopped watching.

After spending a few more days inside this special space, Yuan's eyes suddenly turned golden, resembling that of the Dragon's eyes.

When the Dragon noticed the change in Yuan's eyes, it was inwardly shocked by Yuan's progress.

'This human has already comprehended the Dragon's Gaze to such an extent?! It's only been a week since we started!' The Dragon cried inwardly. 'At this rate, I will really lose the bet! To think I, the Great One, would lose to a mere human! Even if it's only something as minor as losing

a bet, it's still more than enough for me to lose face! Luckily for me, we are alone here and I am only an illusion, or the other Divine Beasts would surely turn me into a laughing stock!'

"Why did you stop? Are you tired?" Yuan asked the Dragon when it suddenly stopped using the Dragon's Gaze to destroy planets, forcing him out of his trance and halting his progress briefly.

"No... I am fine. I am only a mere illusion so I cannot experience exhaustion. Let's continue."

The Dragon continued shooting invisible beams from its massive eyes that seemed larger than the planets it was destroying a moment later, and Yuan returned to staring at the scene with a dazed expression on his face.

After watching for a few more hours, Yuan suddenly closed his eyes, yet he could still somehow see the planets being destroyed by the Dragon.

'Enlightenment! This human has entered the state of enlightenment!' The Dragon realized why Yuan suddenly closed his eyes, yet it did not stop destroying stars.

Meanwhile, in the examination room, the Tablet of Comprehension began changing colors again.

The red light grew darker and darker, until it was no longer red and completely pitch black, resembling the void.

"80 percent?! He'd just reached 70 percent an hour ago! Why did his progress suddenly increase so exponentially?!" Xue Jiye covered her mouth from shock.

Even the sect elders in the spectators' room were puzzled by Yuan's results.

"This... Could this be enlightenment?" One of the sect elders asked in a weird tone, sounding as though he was doubting himself. However, Yuan experiencing enlightenment was the only logical explanation for the sudden change.

Of course, enlightenments are incredibly rare moments that most Cultivators can live even their entire life without experiencing it a single time.

Meanwhile, Yuan was already experiencing his second enlightenment. If the sect elders knew this, they would literally lose their minds, as none of them have experienced the state of enlightenment yet.

A few more hours passed inside Yuan's mind, and he suddenly opened his eyes.

The second Yuan opened his eyes, a profound ripple appeared around him and spread throughout the endless void, and his golden eyes were glowing brighter than ever before.

A notification also appeared before him a moment later.

«You have learned 'Dragon's Gaze'!»

«Rank: Ancient»

«Mastery Level: 1»

«Description: A technique created by the 'Great One'. A single gaze will cause Immortals to bow and the Heavens to tremble in fear!»

'Ancient-rank?' Yuan raised an eyebrow at this unfamiliar rank.

Meanwhile, in the outside world, an announcement appeared for all Players to witness.

«Player Yuan has become the world's first Player to have learned an Ancient-rank skill! Congratulations!»

This announcement dumbfounded and shocked every player in every location across the world.

The players were dumbfounded because they have never heard of an 'Ancient-rank' skill before until today and shocked because Player Yuan

made yet another appearance.

Meanwhile, inside the Dragon Essence Temple, the sect elders within the spectators' room were shaking from excitement when the Tablet of Comprehension suddenly changed colors, turning into a beautiful and majestic golden light!

"He did it! 90 percent comprehension! He has reached the Founder's results! And he did it in less than one day!" The sect elders rejoiced as though they were watching their own child.

"Just 10 more percent and he'll make history... However, overcoming these last 10 percent is like trying to reach the heavens; it won't be easy at all, and it'll probably be even harder to achieve than the previous 90 percent..." Long Yijun mumbled with a serious expression on his face.

"Well, he still has six more days to comprehend the last 10 percent. Even if he doesn't, he's already surpassed the Founder in terms of cultivation talent and comprehension skills. We must nurture this young man and spare no expense on him no matter what," Elder Xuan spoke with a profound expression on his face.

Back inside Yuan's mind, the Dragon stared at Yuan with a baffled gaze.

"3,000... You have managed to learn Dragon's Gaze after watching it less than 3,000 times. Compared to the previous human, you are... No, it would be disrespectful to you if I were to compare you to someone who needed years of effort to learn the technique while you did it in less than a week inside this space."

"How strong is an Ancient-rank technique?" Yuan asked the Dragon afterward.

"The Ancient-rank is one rank above the Divine-rank." The Dragon responded, and it continued, "However, even though it's only one rank higher, it's countless times stronger than any Divine-rank technique out there."

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Chapter 110 - Seal Of Approval

"If you compare Ancient-rank techniques to Divine-rank, the difference is like heaven and earth or Immortals and mortals— it's so vast that they're almost incomparable." The Dragon said to Yuan.

"However, it will also be much harder to train and master than Divine-rank techniques—"

The Dragon suddenly stopped talking halfway through its sentence and looked at Yuan with a weird gaze, and then it continued a moment later, "Well, knowing your talent, it'll probably be no different than a Divine-rank technique, and you'll master it incredibly fast."

"Anyway, you have managed to surpass my expectations, broadened my views with your comprehension talents, and even won a bet against this Great One. Therefore, as promised, I shall now bestow you a special reward."

The Dragon proceeded to close its eyes for a minute.

Once the Dragon reopened its eyes, a golden beam of light shot out from its eyes and pierced straight into Yuan's forehead.

"Whoa!"

After watching the Dragon destroy planets with its gaze thousands of times, Yuan naturally responded to the golden beam by jolting his body in a startled manner, even feeling his heart skip a beat. However, when he realized that his body didn't explode like the stars, he released a sigh of relief.

A few moments later, once the golden beam disappeared, another notification appeared before Yuan.

«You have received the Great One's Seal of Approval»

"Seal of Approval...?" Yuan mumbled, feeling as though nothing about his body had changed after receiving the Seal of Approval.

"What can I do with this seal?" Yuan asked the Dragon afterward.

"With my Seal of Approval, you will have a chance to obtain my Legacy." The Dragon spoke in a calm voice.

"Legacy...?" Yuan raised his eyebrows. Is it something like Xiao Hua's Legacy?

The Dragon continued to speak a moment later, "Go to the Dragon Temple and find my statue. If you use Dragon's Gaze on the statue, it will activate a hidden formation, which will require the Seal of Approval to fully activate. As for what comes afterward... you will have to go there and figure it out yourself."

"If you manage to obtain my Legacy, find the real me that exists somewhere in the upper heavens and I will give you a few treasures that will make even powerful Immortals drool with envy. However, since I am merely an illusion in this place, the real me won't recognize you, as we have never truly met before. But as long as you have the Seal of Approval and the Legacy, everything should be fine."

"Do you have any questions, human... No, what is your name? You have earned my respect, so I shall address you as your name." The Dragon suddenly said to him.

"Yuan. My name is Yuan," he responded.

"Then do you have any questions for me, Yuan?"

After pondering for a moment, Yuan asked, "I have heard the name Dragon Temple before but I don't know what it really is. Can you tell me a little bit

about the place? What kind of place is the Dragon Temple?"

The Dragon nodded its massive head before speaking, "The Dragon Temple is a trial that was created by me... the real me countless years ago to challenge the geniuses in the Lower Heavens in hopes of finding someone who can inherit my Legacy. There are also some treasures that can be obtained from the Dragon Temple. The Tablet of Comprehension, for example, is a treasure that Long Chen had found in the Dragon Temple from a challenge."

"Of course, the treasures within the Dragon Temple are worthless compared to the real treasure— my Legacy. If they manage to pass all of the challenges, obtain the Legacy, and find me in the upper heavens, I shall bestow to them unimaginable wealth and priceless treasures that even Immortals and Gods covet."

"However, nobody has managed to find the Legacy to this day, much less obtain it. Perhaps you, Yuan, will become the first person to inherit my Legacy."

Yuan nodded and said, "I will try."

After a moment of silence, the Dragon spoke again, "Your body can endure a few more weeks in this space. Would you like to continue studying the technique?"

"Yes, let's do this until I have to log off for dinner," Yuan said.

"Dinner...?" The Dragon looked at Yuan with a puzzled gaze.

Sometime later, Yuan returned to watching the Dragon obliterating stars with the Dragon's Gaze, further increasing his understanding of the technique.

Meanwhile, inside the spectators' room, the sect elders were in a small conversation.

"The Tablet of Comprehension is glowing a golden light, meaning that he has reached at least 90 percent comprehension of the technique. However, since we have never witnessed anyone achieving 100 percent, we won't be able to tell if he has truly comprehended 100 percent of the technique or not."

"The only thing we can do is wait and see the results. Perhaps the color might change again, or something entirely different might happen. We can guess what might happen for as long as we want but without the results, we will never really know," Long Yijun said to them.

The sect elders nodded, and they returned to staring at the stone tablet for even the slightest change.

Time quickly passed for everyone including Yuan, who got so absorbed in watching the Dragon destroying stars that he'd forgotten about the flow of time.

Sometime later in the real world, Yu Rou returned home from school and went straight to Yuan's room with haste, as Player Yuan's new achievement was being talked about even at her own school!

However, when she entered his room and Yuan didn't greet her, she stopped to ponder.

'Hmm? Brother would normally leave the game and wait for me before I even return. Is he still doing the disciple examination? He did learn an Ancient-rank skill today, so he might still be busy right now... I shouldn't disturb him even if he might miss dinner tonight...'

Afraid that she might accidentally ruin something for Yuan, Yu Rou decided to leave him alone until he decides to log off himself, and she left the room a few moments later to do other things.

Chapter 111 - Talents That Will Make Even The Heavens Jealous!

After learning the Ancient-rank technique, Dragon's Gaze, Yuan remained inside the special space to further study the technique by watching the Great One continuously destroy planets, and because time flows differently in that space, not to mention his state of enlightenment, Yuan forgot about the passage of time and spent two more weeks within the special space without even realizing how much time had passed.

Of course, only a little more than half a day had passed in the outside world, so besides missing dinner and breakfast, Yuan didn't really miss out too much.

Ding!

A system notification suddenly appeared before Yuan, snapping him out of his state of enlightenment.

«Your comprehension for Dragon's Gaze has reached a new level»

«Dragon's Gaze Mastery Level (1) → (2)»

Dragon's Gaze

Rank: Ancient

Mastery Level: 2

Description: A technique created by the 'Great One'. A single gaze will cause Immortals to bow and the Heavens to tremble in fear!

The moment Yuan's Mastery Level increased, the Tablet of Comprehension outside began to tremble.

When the sect elders noticed this, they exclaimed, "Something's going to happen!"

A few seconds later, the Tablet of Comprehension cracked like a mirror, and just like the silver tree from the third exam, it exploded into many pieces before revealing a golden tablet.

"A golden tablet?! Is this what happens when one comprehends 100 percent of the technique?!" Long Yijun shouted out in sheer excitement.

"He really did this! This young man really did it! He has achieved the impossible!"

"Heavens! What just happened?!" Xue Jiye cried out loud when she saw this, yet she was too nervous to investigate it by herself.

Meanwhile, inside Yuan's mind.

"HAHAHAHA!"

The Dragon suddenly burst with laughter, causing the entire universe to tremble, even shattering a few planets by accident.

"You are truly one amusing human, Yuan! I have never seen a mortal with comprehension abilities as ridiculous as yours— not even in the upper heavens! Although there are many cultivation monsters in the upper heavens with heaven-sent talents, they are all Immortals and Gods, and you are the first Spirit Warrior that has managed to baffle me speechless in such a manner!"

The Dragon praised Yuan, something it has never done before ever since its creation by the Tablet of Comprehension, and it continued speaking, "You have talents that will make even the Heavens jealous! However, having such immense talent is not always a good thing, as it can also be a misfortune in the cultivation world where everybody is either plotting or

destroying one another, especially the envious humans who will do everything in their power to destroy those superior to them if they have the capabilities."

"Only those with great talent and a powerful background will truly rise in the cultivation world, whilst everyone will require an immense amount of luck and skills to survive. I don't know your background, but with your talents, I can only imagine how many people will try to destroy you before you become too powerful to stop, especially since you are only a Spirit Warrior."

"If I were you, I wouldn't reveal my true talents to everyone and remain as lowkey as possible."

Yuan nodded, "I understand."

"Anyway, you have only a few more days at most inside this space. What do you want to do?" The Dragon asked him a moment later.

"Although not much time has passed in the real world, it still feels as though I had lived here for a few weeks, and I am beginning to miss my sister's voice, so I'll leave now," Yuan said.

"Very well... I shall let you leave now."

The Dragon's eyes began glowing. However, before teleporting Yuan away, the Dragon said, "I truly hope that you will obtain the Legacy and meet the real me in the upper heavens. Good luck, Yuan."

A moment later, Yuan opened his eyes, and the first thing he noticed was the golden tablet standing majestically standing before him.

'Huh?' Yuan raised his eyebrows, unaware why the stone tablet had suddenly turned golden.

When Xue Jiye noticed that Yuan had finally opened his eyes after sitting there for almost 2 days, she called out to him, "Are you okay?!"

"Hm?"

Yuan turned around to look at the pretty young lady that was approaching him, completely unaware that his eyes were still glowing golden, resembling the eyes of Divine Beasts.

"What is this feeling?!"

When Xue Jiye looked into Yuan's golden eyes, she felt an indescribable sense of fear and despair that filled in her heart that caused her body to tremble.

Thud!

Xue Jiye fell on her butt the next second, and a weird sensation could be felt coming from between her legs before a warm sensation followed.

"Ah! Don't look at me!" Xue Jiye quickly cried out loud with a flushed face and covered her face with her arms when she realized that she'd accidentally pissed herself after looking into Yuan's eyes that were unknowingly using Dragon's Gaze.

"Eh? Are you okay?"

However, Yuan was still unaware that he was naturally using Dragon's Gaze and approached Xue Jiye with his golden eyes still glowing brightly.

"Ahhh~!"

Xue Jiye quickly realized that blocking Yuan from her views did not help her situation at all when she could still feel his piercing gaze even though she was not looking at him.

"S-Stop! Are you doing this on purpose?! Stop looking at me and turn around!" Xue Jiye shouted in an angry voice.

"Okay..."

Although Yuan was puzzled as to why Xue Jiye was telling him to look away and why she sounded angry, he listened to her and turned around.

A few moments later, a portal appeared a few meters away from Yuan, and a couple of figures walked out of the portal.

"S-Sect Master! Grand Elder!" Xue Jiye was surprised to suddenly see their faces, but it was not too shocking, as Yuan's results were simply that ridiculous.

"You can return to your living quarters for now, Disciple Xue. However, don't say a single word about what you saw here today. I will speak with you later," Long Yijun said to her with a serious expression on his face.

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Chapter 112 - End Of The Disciple Examination

"Y-Yes, Sect Leader!" Xue Jiye quickly stood up before making her way towards the portal and disappearing from the scene, leaving behind a trail of glistening liquid and a small puddle of clear water.

Once Xue Jiye left the place, Long Yijun and Elder Xuan turned their attention to Yuan, but when they saw his golden eyes behind the black jade mask, their bodies uncontrollably trembled from a dreadful feeling that made them feel as though they were standing before a powerful beast, almost like they were in a life-or-death situation.

Despite their cultivation base as Spirit Masters, they felt helpless before a mere Spirit Warrior just from his gaze; it was an incomprehensible feeling for the two experts.

"Daoist Yuan... Can you do something about your eyes?" Long Yijun asked Yuan a moment later with a weird smile on his face.

"My eyes? What about my eyes?" Yuan asked, still unaware that his Dragon's Gaze was active.

"It's glowing golden, and it doesn't feel comfortable being stared at by it," Long Yijun said.

"Oh, I'm sorry, I didn't know it was active... No wonder why my eyes were feeling a little bit different than usual," Yuan closed his eyes and deactivated the skill.

Because he'd gotten used to keeping Dragon's Gaze activated inside the special space for many days without rest, it felt as natural as breathing, hence why he didn't notice it instantly.

Once the golden eyes were gone, Long Yijun released a relieved sigh before speaking, "Hello, Yuan. My name is Long Yijun, and I am the current Sect Leader for the Dragon Essence Temple, and this over here is—"

Elder Xuan stepped forward and extended his arm for a handshake, "How are you doing, Yuan? My surname is Xuan, Xuan Zan."

"Xuan...?" Yuan raised his eyebrows after hearing this familiar surname.

"That's right. I am Xuan Wuhan's grandfather. She has already told me about you," Elder Xuan said.

"Oh! So you're Xuan Wuhan's grandfather! She also told me to come see you if I ever come to the Dragon Essence Temple!" Yuan shook his hand.

"Yes. If you'd come to me straight away, I could've made you a disciple right away, and you wouldn't have needed to participate in this examination. With that being said, I am also relieved that you didn't come to me first, or else we would've never realized the full extent of your talents." Elder Xuan said with a smile on his face.

Long Yijun suddenly began walking, and he stood before the golden tablet a moment later with his hands caressing the solid tablet with a mesmerizing look on his face.

"Congratulations, Yuan... or should I call you Disciple Yuan now that you have passed the exam? Either way, you have achieved something nobody—not even our Founder could have achieved by comprehending 100 percent of the technique given to you by the Tablet of Comprehension within 7 days. Hell, you'd even completed it in 2 days!" Long Yijun said to him a moment later.

"W-Wait a second... two days? I have been here for two days?" Yuan asked them with a dumbfounded look on his face.

"Yes." Long Yijun nodded.

"I-I'll be right back!"

Yuan immediately logged off to see if Yu Rou was still around.

"Yu Rou?" Yuan immediately called for her after logging off.

"The Young Lady has already left for school, Young Master." A clear voice that belonged to a young lady suddenly responded to him, but it was not Yu Rou's voice.

"That voice... Is that you, Meixiu?" Yuan asked.

"Yes, Young Master. This is Meixiu speaking," she responded.

"I see... How long have I been in the game?" he asked her a moment later.

"The Young Master has been playing since yesterday morning, and he's missed two meals— last night's dinner and this morning's breakfast. The Young Lady has ordered me to standby here just in case you log off and require assistance," Meixiu said.

Because Meixiu was Yu Rou's personal maid and also the same age as her, Yu Rou trusted Meixiu enough to leave her alone with Yuan, and she would let Meixiu take care of Yuan whenever she could not.

As for why Meixiu wasn't present the previous time Yu Rou was unable to attend Yuan, it was simply because she was busy with another task.

However, it was not only Yu Rou who trusted Meixiu, as Yuan also trusted her, even treating her like a friend, as they have known each other for many years— even before he was crippled.

"Would you like to eat breakfast... or lunch now, Young Master?"

"It's okay, I'm not hungry. Since Yu Rou has already gone to school, I will return to the game for now. You don't need to stay here either," Yuan said to her.

"I cannot do that, as the Young Lady has specifically ordered me to stay here until she returns," Meixiu said.

"...You're just like your mother, always so serious with your job, even though you're around the same age as Yu Rou. It's admirable, really."

"Thank you for your compliments, Young Master."

"I'll go now. You can do whatever you want." After saying that, Yuan went back into the cultivation world.

After returning back to the cultivation world, Long Yijun continued speaking to Yuan as though he'd never left in the first place, "Not only have you achieved something nobody has ever achieved before, but you have done it in an unbelievably short time! If I didn't witness your results with my own eyes, I wouldn't have believed it even if someone beats me to death!"

"However, while your achievements are definitely incredible, we also have to keep it a secret for now, or it might bring you— even the Dragon Essence Temple unnecessary trouble. I will explain more to you later, but for now, let's get you out of this place."

"What about the special jade slip?" Yuan suddenly asked him.

"Hahaha! Don't worry about something like that. I have already decided to let you enter the Dragon Temple!" Long Yijun said, and he continued, "Come, let's continue our conversation somewhere more comfortable."

Chapter 113 - Introducing Himself

After passing the final exam and meeting Long Yijun and Elder Xuan, Yuan followed them out of the examination area through the portal and straight into the spectators' room with the other sect elders present.

"Where is this?" Yuan looked around the unfamiliar scenery.

"This is the spectators' room, where high-ranking sect elders can watch the disciple examination and see if there are any talented participants they can accept as disciples." Long Yijun said.

"Hello, Daoist Yuan. Why don't you be my disciple? I can promise you that we'll have a 'good' time together," one of the female sect elders, who had a mature and enchanting figure, suddenly said to Yuan with an alluring gaze, even winking her bright eyes at him.

"How shameless of you, Elder Shan! The Sect Master and Grand Elder are present, you know!" Another sect elder quickly scolded her.

"So what? It's not like they don't already know my character." Elder Shan shrugged, and she continued, "Furthermore, someone as talented as Yuan... I would do anything to make him my disciple... hehe..."

Elder Shan glared at Yuan with a hungry look on her beautiful face, almost like a predator before its prey.

Yuan swallowed nervously when he saw this, as he has never been glared at with such a chilling gaze before.

"You're scaring him, Elder Shan." Elder Xuan said to her, and he continued, "I know you all want him to be your disciple, but we can talk about that

later. For now, let's make sure he's comfortable and understands the situation that we're in."

Sometime later, Yuan took a seat with the others sitting around him.

"For starters, let's introduce ourselves." Long Yijun said. "Once again, I am Long Yijun, the current Sect Master of the Dragon Essence Temple."

Elder Xuan went next and said, "I am one of three Grand Elders, Xuan Zan."

The mature female elder then said, "Surnamed Shan— Shan Shang, and I am in charge of the Core Disciples. If you are ever feeling lonely or bored, come find me, okay, Daoist Yuan? I'll entertain you."

"..."

After a moment of awkward silence, the next elder in the room spoke, "Xin Ming, and I am also in charge of the Core Disciples alongside Elder Shan."

"Bai Ling, and I am in charge of the Disciplinary Hall. If you ever run into trouble, whether it be with another disciple or a sect elder, you can come find me."

Long Yijun then said, "There are a few more sect elders that had seen your performance from this place, but they had to leave early for other duties. Would you like to introduce yourself? A brief introduction about yourself and a little about why you decided to join our Dragon Essence Temple."

Yuan nodded and took off his black jade mask, revealing to them his handsome and young face.

"Oh my! You're much younger and more handsome than I'd expected! I am definitely going to make you my disciple now!" Elder Shan's eyes flickered with excitement after seeing Yuan's face, and she even licked her lips in a weird manner.

Yuan tried his best to ignore the weird woman and said, "My name is Yuan, and I am 18 years old. I have only recently become a Cultivator and I want

to learn more about the cultivation world, so I came to the Dragon Essence Temple to broaden my views!"

"..."

To Yuan's surprise, nobody there responded to him, and they all stared at him with wide eyes filled with shock.

"Y-You're only 18 years old? And you became a Cultivator only recently? How recently are we talking about? A few years ago?" Long Yijun was the first to snap out of his daze and ask Yuan.

"No, I became a Cultivator only a few weeks ago," Yuan responded with an innocent-looking expression on his face.

"A FEW WEEKS AGO?!"

Everybody in the room simultaneously exclaimed in a shocked voice with one of them even breaking his chair and falling onto the floor.

"Just where on earth did you come from? If you don't mind, can you tell us your background? Which powerful family do you belong to? I can promise you that it won't leave this room, and no matter where you came from, we don't treat you any different—I swear on it as the Sect Master of the Dragon Essence Temple!" Long Yijun asked him in a nervous voice.

"Why does everyone think I am from a powerful family?" Yuan responded with puzzlement, and he continued, "I don't belong to any powerful family."

"How is that possible? What about your parents? They must be powerful Cultivators, right?" Elder Xuan asked him next.

"No, my parents are not Cultivators. They are musicians," Yuan said. Since he didn't have a family in this world, he told them about his family in the real world.

"What?! Your parents are mortals?! And they gave birth to a cultivation prodigy like you?! What are the Heavens thinking?!" Long Yijun cried out

loud.

It was as though the Heavens created a cultivation prodigy like Yuan just to mess with every Cultivator in the world. Not only is Yuan from a common background and a family of mortals, but he has talents that surpass even the Founder of the Dragon Essence Temple, who was once recognized as the number one expert in the entire Lower Heavens! If this is not spitting in the face of every Cultivator, especially those born from a powerful family, then what is?

"If what you say is true... and I don't mean to doubt you... then we have a serious issue at hand," Long Yijun spoke a moment later with a serious expression on his face.

The other sect elders also nodded their heads with grim looks on their faces, instantly turning the atmosphere heavy.

"Eh? Why would it be an issue that I am not from a powerful family?" Yuan asked, still unaware of the situation he was in.

"Well, to put it simply, there will be countless people who will become envious of your talents, and because you have no powerful family backing you, there will be nothing to stop these people from trying to harm you—destroy you before you can grow too powerful," Long Yijun said to him.

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Chapter 114 - The Importance Of Having A Strong Backing

"You wish to learn more about the cultivation world, right? Well, the first thing you need to know about the cultivation world is its brutal and unforgiving nature." Long Yijun continued.

"There are many selfish and coldhearted Cultivators out there who are without reason and will do everything in their power to bully those weaker than themselves and try to destroy those above them if they get the chance."

"This is why it's extremely important to have a powerful backer or an influential background, especially if you are talented, as they will be able to protect you to a certain extent, and the more powerful your backing the safer you'll be in the cultivation world. This is another reason why many Cultivators aim for the most prestigious sects, as that will make them feel safer."

"If you don't have a strong backing or come from a powerful family, other Cultivators will be able to bully you without needing to worry about the repercussions. If you have a powerful background, on the other hand, people will have to think twice before they want to mess with you."

"Do you now understand why it's so important to have a backing and connections in the cultivation world? Cultivators... they can be heartless and selfish creatures that will do anything to achieve their own goals, even if they have to drag down others in order to do so."

'I see... The dragon also said the same thing, but it didn't go into too much depth...' Yuan thought to himself after hearing Long Yijun's long explanation on why it was important for him to have a strong backing.

"I understand," Yuan nodded afterward.

Long Yijun continued to speak a moment later, "Now back to our situation. You have immense talent— talents that will make many, many Cultivators jealous, yet you do not come from a powerful family that can protect you, hence why it's a problem."

"While the Dragon Essence Temple can protect you to a certain extent, and we will do everything in our power to protect you as long as you are a disciple here, there are no guarantees, as there are powerful factions and Cultivators out there in this vast world that even we cannot deal with."

"Therefore, I suggest hiding your real talent from the world until you have sufficient backings. Of course, that is not to say you shouldn't show off your talents— just overdo it... like what you did during the third and final exam..."

Yuan nodded.

"Now onto the second matter... Elder Xuan, do you want to take over?" Long Yijun asked him.

Elder Xuan nodded before looking at Yuan and speaking, "You said that you came to the Dragon Essence Temple for experience, right? I have heard from my granddaughter about how you do not want to be restricted like normal disciples and wish to travel freely. Normally, only Core Disciples will have such luxury, but we will make it an exception for you since you are already at the Core Disciples' level."

"Although you have just passed the examination and become a disciple, it would make no sense to make someone at your cultivation level an Outer Court— even an Inner Court disciple. However, with that being said, we also cannot just make you a Core Disciple, as that has never happened before and it would upset many of the Core Disciples."

"Therefore, we'll make you an Outer Court disciple in name so that you can experience the sect from the beginning exactly like you wanted while giving you Core Disciple privileges and benefits, so you'll actually be a

Core Disciple disguised as an Outer Court disciple until you pass the Core Disciple examination and become one officially."

"How does that sound, everyone?" Elder Xuan asked the others for their feedback.

"That sounds pretty interesting," Elder Shan said, and she continued, "We can keep him hidden from our enemies since they tend to only look at the Inner Disciples and Core Disciples."

"I also approve of this. However, how are we going to hide his cultivation base?" Elder Xin asked.

"I will handle that," Elder Shan said. "I have a pill that'll disguise his real cultivation base and make him appear much weaker than he actually is."

Long Yijun looked at Yuan and asked him, "Are you okay with being an Outer Court disciple for now? If you wish, we can make you an Inner Court disciple instead."

However, Yuan shook his head and said, "I want to experience a normal sect life as intended, which means I start from the bottom and walk my way to the top."

While it was a little too late for Yuan to live a 'normal' sect life, Long Yijun and the other sect elders did not say anything and decided to let Yuan live that illusion for now.

"Then it's decided. Starting today, you will be an Outer Court disciple, but if you ever need something— anything at all— just let one of us know and we'll assist you to the best of our abilities without making it too obvious. We'll give you our communication jade slip later so you can contact us whenever you feel the need." Long Yijun said.

A moment later, Long Yijun continued, "Disciple Yuan, I have one... no, two more important matters to discuss with you before I can let you go so bear with me. The first one is about a place called Mystic Realm that we plan on having you participate in next month, and the second matter is

about the Dragon Temple that will most likely happen after the Mystic Realm."

"Mystic Realm...? What's that?" Yuan asked.

"To put it simply, it's a massive competition that happens only once every ten years where all of the elite sects from around the world send their most talented disciples to participate in the Mystic Realm—a mysterious place that contains many challenges and treasures, and the higher your sect ranks the more rewards and fame you'll obtain." Long Yijun explained.

And he continued a moment later in a passionate voice, "Our Dragon Essence Temple ranked 7th for the last event, but with you on our side this year, I have no doubt that we'll achieve at least top 3!"

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Chapter 115 - Accepting A Master

"Every sect will be given a certain amount of slots depending on their results from the previous competition, and we managed to secure 3 slots for this year's Mystic Realm," Long Yijun said.

"One of those spots will be given to you. Of course, we're not going to ask you to participate without anything in return, so we'll give you full access to the Profound Pavilion, where you can learn all kinds of techniques between the Mortal-rank to Earth-rank. There are also a few Heaven-rank techniques available, but you'll need to be accompanied by one of us in order to access those."

"Furthermore, whatever you obtain from the Mystic Realm, we'll let you keep them. Normally, the disciples are required to hand in the treasures they find inside the Mystic Realm, but we'll make it an exception for you."

"What do you think? Are you willing to participate in the Mystic Realm for the Dragon Essence Temple?" Long Yijun asked him afterward.

Yuan nodded without hesitation, "Sure. I don't mind participating."

Since there was no reason for him to refuse, and he was curious about this Mystic Realm, Yuan accepted their request.

"Great! Then let's talk about the Dragon Temple. The Dragon Temple is a mythical place discovered by our Founder, Long Chen, and he built the Dragon Essence Temple around it in order to protect it. It's a mysterious place with many challenging tests, and you'll be rewarded for passing those tests."

"The only reason why we are not sending more disciples in there is simply because it requires a tremendous amount of resources and effort to open the

place for even a single person, and there's a high chance the Dragon Temple might refuse entrance if you are not talented enough, hence why we only allow those who have exceptional results during the disciple examination to enter the Dragon Temple." Long Yijun explained to him.

"You wish to enter the Dragon Temple, right?"

"Yes, I do." Yuan nodded.

"Then I'll immediately start preparing for it now. It should be ready for you shortly after the Mystic Realm if I begin now— that's just how much effort is required to open it."

"Do you have any questions for us?" Long Yijun asked him a moment later.

"No, not really..." Yuan shook his head.

"Good, then we can finally—"

"Wait a second!"

Elder Shan suddenly interrupted Long Yijun.

"What's the matter, Elder Shan?" They looked at her with raised eyebrows.

"We still haven't decided on who should be Yuan's Master, and I would like to volunteer," she said with a stern expression on her face.

"..."

The place quickly became silent, as the sect elders there were well aware of Elder Shan's stubborn character. If she truly wanted Yuan to become her disciple, it'll be near impossible to make her give up.

"Why don't we let the young man himself decide such an important matter?" Elder Xuan said, and he turned to look at Yuan.

"What do you think, Disciple Yuan? Although disciples are not required to have a Master, it's highly recommended that you get one, as they can

provide you with resources and advice for your cultivation. Furthermore, having a Master is also considered as having a 'backing' within the sect."

"How about it, little brother? Why don't you come with this big sister here? I'll promise you that you'll never have a boring day when you're my disciple." Elder Shan suddenly stood up and approached Yuan with weird leg movements, appearing incredibly tempting and seductive with every step, and even the other sect elders couldn't help but swallow nervously after seeing her feminine charm.

"I have only ever accepted female disciples before, but I'll make it an exception for you. My disciples are also very beautiful and popular in the sect with countless admirers, so if you become my disciple, you'll get to meet with them often." Elder Shan walked behind Yuan and leaned on him with her large and heavy racks pressing down on top of Yuan's head.

"I..." Yuan was speechless. Although he does not understand why Elder Shan was acting so weird and clingy, his heart felt an indescribable sense of danger when around her, almost like a baby rabbit before a hungry tiger.

"Forget about her, young man. Become my, Xin Ming's disciple! Although she may look very young and attractive, don't let her appearance deceive you, as she's actually an old hag over 300 years old!"

"Who are you calling an old hag, you wrinkly old man?!" Elder Shan quickly removed one of her shoes and tossed it at Elder Xin with an enraged look on her face.

"How dare you throw your smelly shoes at me!" Elder Xin exclaimed.

"Hahaha! Ignore those two idiots, Brother Yuan. I can see clear righteousness coming from your eyes, and I believe that you'll fit in at our Disciplinary Hall perfectly!" Bai Ling laughed out loud.

"Disciple Yuan, you are not limited to just sect elders, you know? If you want, I can also accept you as my disciple," Long Yijun suddenly said.

"Though, with your monstrous comprehension abilities, I doubt any of us will be your Master for long," he continued with a bittersweet smile on his face.

Sometime later, Elder Shan asked Yuan, "What do you think, little brother? Who do you want as a Master?"

"Uhhh..."

After a moment of silence, Yuan spoke, "Since I cannot really decide, can I just accept all of you as my Master?"

"You want all of us? My, you're quite the greedy one, but that's fine too." Elder Shan chuckled after hearing his answer.

"Can I not have more than one Master?" Yuan asked.

"Although not very common, it's normal for disciples to have more than one Master at a time since it's not possible to learn everything from one Master. Though I don't think there has been a disciple who has had the Sect Master and many high-ranking sect elders as Master simultaneously before..." Elder Xuan said to him.

"Then again, you are not a normal disciple, and there'll always be a first for everything— just like how you'd demonstrated during the disciple examination."

Chapter 116 - Pill Of Concealmen

"So? Does everyone here agree to have Disciple Yuan as their disciple?" Long Yijun asked them a moment later, and he continued, "I'll be completely honest— his talent is simply too much for us to keep to ourselves, so instead of being selfish, it's best if we all contribute to teaching him about the cultivation world for the best results. After all, it might affect his growth negatively if he has only one Master."

"I have no qualms about that decision," Bai Ling said with a calm expression on his face.

"Me neither," Elder Xin said.

Everyone there then turned to look at Elder Shan, who held a hard-to-read expression on her beautiful face.

After a moment of silence, she sighed out loud, "Fine, I'll share him. Although I'd rather keep him for myself, what the Sect Master said makes sense. I doubt I'll be able to train someone as talented as him properly, and I'll only slow down his progress."

Sometime later, Long Yijun and the other sect elders there handed Yuan their communication jade slip so that Yuan could communicate with them whenever he wanted.

"By the way, is there anything that I need to do now that I have accepted all of you as my Master?" Yuan asked them. "What about the lectures?"

"We do give private lectures to our disciples every month and public lectures once a year, but you are not required to attend either of them. If you have any questions regarding cultivation or need resources for cultivation, you can just let us know using the communication jade slip. Furthermore,

because you are still only an Outer Disciple, we'll avoid physically meeting with each other as much as possible since we don't normally communicate with disciples in person, and I don't want the other disciples thinking that we are favoring you too much, as that might affect the entire sect as a whole." Long Yijun said to him.

"I understand." Yuan nodded.

"Here's a few more things before we let you go." Elder Xuan then handed Yuan two separate medallions.

"The silver medallion will allow you to go to the Treasury Hall and obtain as many resources as you need for your cultivation— just don't overdo it, as we don't have an unlimited supply of resources. I will speak with the elder in charge there and let him know of your existence to avoid any problems."

"As for the gold medallion, that'll grant you full access to the Profound Pavilion. I'll also let the elder in charge of that place know about you."

"Don't lose them; it'll be problematic if someone that's not supposed to have them gets a hold of them."

"I won't lose them," Yuan said with a serious expression on his face.

Sometime later, Elder Shan said to Yuan, "Come with me, little brother. I still have to give you the pill that'll disguise your real cultivation base. However, I don't have it on me, so we'll have to get it in my room."

"Okay..." Yuan nodded innocently without thinking too much about it.

However, Elder Xin blocked Yuan's path and said to Elder Shan, "You can go back by yourself and return here once you have the pill. I don't trust you one bit with him, especially if you'll be alone with him. Who knows what you'll do to this innocent boy when you're alone with him."

"Haaa... You are thinking too lowly of me, Elder Xin. Do you really believe that I would lay my hands on my own disciple?" Elder Shan sighed with a

disappointed look on her face, and she continued, "Despite my character, I am still a maiden, you know?"

"Hmph!" Elder Xin coldly snorted, not even bothering to answer her.

"Fine... I'll be right back..." Elder Shan shook her head before leaving the building.

While Elder Shan left to grab the pill, Long Yijun handed Yuan a medallion of his own and said, "This is the Absolute Authority medallion, and only the Sect Master can hand it out. As long as you have this, nobody in the sect will dare to touch you. However, don't go flaunting it every chance you get and only use it during emergencies, and of course, don't lose it."

"Thank you," Yuan nodded as he tossed another medallion into his Spatial Ring.

Once Elder Shan returned a few minutes later, she handed Yuan a black pill the size of a fingernail.

"Eat this and nobody but Spirit Masters and above will be able to tell your real cultivation base," Elder Shan handed him the pill.

[Pill of Concealment] [Tier 2] [Purity: 92%]

[Effects: Temporarily conceals your cultivation base by 7 levels for 30 days]

[Description: Only works if you are below Spirit Master]

After tossing the pill into his mouth and swallowing it with the help of some water, Yuan could feel his aura being suppressed, yet his strength remained the same.

"There— now you're only a 7th level Spirit Apprentice, just enough to qualify as an Inner Disciple," Elder Shan said afterward.

Sometime later, Long Yijun opened another portal to the disciple examination and said to Yuan, "Once you return to the examination, just

enter the gate behind the Tablet of Comprehension and you'll be teleported to the gathering area where everyone that has passed the examination will be gathered. Here's your token; it's proof that you have passed the disciple examination."

"Although we won't see each other for a while, we'll always be watching over you, so go ahead and enjoy life as a disciple until the Mystic Realm," Elder Xuan said to him.

"Good luck, Brother Yuan." Bai Ling said to him.

"Try not to cause too much trouble." Elder Xin said with a smile.

Lastly, Elder Shan said to him before kissing the palm of her hands and blowing it towards his direction, "If you are ever feeling lonely, come find me at Blossom Peak."

"I will see you all later, Seniors. Thank you for everything so far." Yuan bowed to them before entering the portal and disappearing from the room.

Chapter 117 - Golden Symbols

Once Yuan entered the portal and disappeared from the spectators' room, Long Yijun and all of the sect elders there sat down in a chair with an exhausted expression on their faces.

"Heavens... That was exhausting..." Elder Xin was the first to speak there, and he continued a moment later, "It's really difficult being around a genius like Yuan. There's simply something about his aura that frightens me."

"You got that feeling too? Although I cannot tell what it is, there's something fearsome hidden within Yuan, and it felt like there were always two pairs of eyes watching me at all times." Long Yijun said with his back soaked in sweat. "Perhaps I'm just imagining things, and it's just his natural aura."

"There will soon be a massive ripple sweeping the entire cultivation world, especially after the Mystic Realm, when Yuan's existence will be known to the rest of the world and to all of the elite sects out there, and we'll need to be prepared before that happens, or our Dragon Essence Temple will be in danger," Elder Xuan said to them with a serious expression on his face.

"Yes, this is a serious risk that our Dragon Essence Temple is taking, but this is what usually happens when an extraordinary genius appears in the cultivation world," Long Yijun said, and he continued, "However, we cannot be afraid to take risks, or our Dragon Essence Temple will never stand at the top again."

"By the way, I just realized this, but we never asked Yuan what kind of cultivation technique he'd received from the Tablet of Comprehension. Since his examination results were on the Founder's level, there's a high chance that he'd learned the same technique our Founder learned— a

Divine-rank technique if the rumors are correct." Bai Ling suddenly said to them.

"There's no need to ask him since I witnessed it for myself." Long Yijun said.

"Really? What kind of technique did he learn?" Bai Ling asked with a curious look on his face.

Long Yijun closed his eyes to recall Yuan's golden eyes before speaking a moment later, "The technique our Founder used to dominate the Lower Heavens... It was an otherworldly technique that allowed him to completely freeze his opponents' movements by instilling deep fear into their very soul with a mere gaze, right? According to some of the records that were written by witnesses that have seen our Founder's battles, our Founder's eyes would glow golden whenever he activates this technique."

"And when I met Yuan for the first time after he finished his exam, his eyes were glowing golden, and it was able to make even a peak Spirit Master such as myself experience fear."

The place quickly turned silent after Long Yijun ended his sentence.

"If Yuan really learned the Founder's technique, there's a very high chance that he'll dominate the Lower Heavens like the Founder had—it's only a matter of when he'll achieve it," Elder Shan said with a serious look on her face for once. "Therefore, we should protect him at all cost."

"I agree with Elder Shan. Our Founder was so talented during his time that there hasn't been anyone who managed to reach his heights even 100,000 years later. If Yuan, who has talents that surpass even the Founder, we must make sure he grows up properly." Bai Ling said.

"If we can protect Yuan until he can dominate the Lower Heavens, our Dragon Essence Temple will once again rise to the top. If we fail, however, our Dragon Essence Temple might crumble." Elder Xin said with a pondering expression on his face.

"Is there even a need to think about this? Of course, we will protect Yuan even if we have to risk the entire Dragon Essence Temple! I'm sure the Founder would also say the same if he was here!" Long Yijun stood up and said.

"I agree with the Sect Master. Who knows what other talents Yuan might be hiding," Elder Xuan said.

"Then it's decided. We'll protect Yuan at all costs," Elder Xin and Elder Bai nodded their heads.

"Someone who's even more talented than our Founder, huh? I can already imagine how the ladies will react once they learn about Yuan. Therefore, I should take advantage of my situation and be the first to act." Elder Shan chuckled with a weird expression on her face.

"Do you have no shame, Elder Shan? You're already 300 years old while Yuan is merely 18 years old. He'll choose your disciples before he even considers you!" Elder Xin laughed out loud.

"One's age becomes inconsequential when you are both Cultivators, especially at the higher levels. You're just jealous that I am going after Yuan while I rejected you 200 years ago." Elder Shan looked at Elder Xin with a smirk on her face.

"..." Elder Xin became speechless after being reminded of his youthful days when he was infatuated with Elder Shan but was ultimately rejected by her.

"Did you really have to bring that up? That's very underhanded of you..." He sighed a moment later.

Meanwhile, after entering the portal, Yuan returned to the examination hall with the golden Tablet of Comprehension still standing there.

Yuan approached the golden tablet and bowed it.

"Thank you for everything. I will try my best to find your Legacy in the Dragon Temple and meet the real you somewhere in the upper heavens."

The Tablet of Comprehension suddenly trembled, and the symbols on the tablet began moving, before emerging from the golden tablet and flying directly at Yuan's body, submerging itself within his body.

"What the?"

Yuan patted his body after the symbols disappeared into his body. Oddly enough, he didn't feel any different, nor did any notifications pop up, so he has no clue as to what had just happened.

Meanwhile, inside Yuan's body, golden symbols appeared on all of his bones, yet neither Xiao Hua nor Feng Yixiao could see or sense the golden symbols.

Sometime later, Yuan left the examination hall through the gate, becoming the first person to complete the disciple examination.

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Chapter 118 - Becoming A Disciple

After passing through the gate, Yuan was transported to a gathering area somewhere in the outer areas of the Dragon Essence Temple.

"What? You have passed the exam already? What's your name? And let me see your token."

The sect elders in charge of the new disciples were dumbfounded when they saw Yuan appearing from the gates, as the other participants are still in the final examination trying to comprehend their techniques, and even if some of them have already managed to comprehend 10 percent before the seven day period, they would always try to study the technique as much as they can before their time is up.

"Here you go. My name is Yuan."

Yuan showed the sect elders the token that proved that he'd indeed passed the examination.

Once the sect elders confirmed the integrity of the token, they said to Yuan, "Very well. Come with me to gather your uniform and identification token."

Yuan proceeded to follow the sect elder into this building where he was handed three sets of Outer Court disciple uniforms.

"How old are you and what is your cultivation base?" The sect elder then asked him.

"18 years old, seventh level Spirit Apprentice," Yuan responded.

"Seventh level Spirit Apprentice? That's pretty high for your age, and you are already qualified to take the Inner Court disciple examination. However,

you must be a disciple for at least a month before you can take the exam."

After recording Yuan's information into a logbook, the sect elder handed Yuan his identification token and another item before speaking, "This is the Dragon Essence Temple's rule book; it contains everything you can and cannot do as a disciple of the sect. If you break any rules, you'll be sent to the Disciplinary Hall for punishment. If you break enough rules or one major rule, your disciple status will be renounced and you will no longer be a disciple of the sect, and worst-case scenario, you'll have your cultivation crippled before being thrown out with death even a possibility. Therefore, I highly urge you to read and memorize the entire rule book."

"I understand," Yuan nodded.

"Also, there will be a small lecture that will be held later that all newly accepted disciples must attend before they are allowed into the sect, as it will teach you more about the sect and things you are expected to do as a disciple. However, since you have finished the examination much faster than others, you'll have to wait a few days until the disciple examination ends."

The sect elder then pointed to a long building with many doors not too far away from them and said, "You can stay in one of those rooms until then. The lecture will happen in seven days when the examination officially ends. Take this time to read the rule book."

"Okay. Thank you, Senior." Yuan bowed to the sect elder before going into one of the rooms.

Once he was inside the room, Yuan looked at the small place with a speechless look on his face.

There was barely any free space in the room, and besides a small bed that could not really be called a bed because it was completely made of stone, and the toilet, there was nothing else in the room.

"I am supposed to live here for an entire week? This is ridiculous!" Yuan sighed loudly before sitting on the cold, hard 'bed'. Luckily for him, he can

simply log off the game and wait in the real world inside his comfortable room. However, such a thing was impossible for the people of this world, and Yuan pitied them.

"Congratulations on passing the disciple examination and becoming a disciple of the Dragon Essence Temple, Brother Yuan." Xiao Hua's voice suddenly resounded inside Yuan's head.

"Oh, Xiao Hua. Thank you. And it feels like it's been forever since I last heard your voice," Yuan said.

"Xiao Hua is always with Brother Yuan, and she's always watching him," Xiao Hua said.

"Congratulations, Young Master; it seems like you have learned another powerful technique," Feng Yixiao's voice resounded next.

"Thank you, Feng Feng."

Because most of the events had happened inside Yuan's mind, neither Xiao Hua nor Feng Yixiao knew about the Great One or anything that happened inside the special space.

After talking with Xiao Hua and Feng Yixiao for a few minutes, Yuan retrieved the Dragon Essence Temple rule book and began reading through it thoroughly, not daring to miss a single sentence, as he didn't want to accidentally break any rules.

"No fighting between disciples. If you have a problem with another disciple, settle it on the stage after notifying a sect elder. Offenders will be punished with 3 months of solitary confinement in the Disciplinary Cave."

"Murder, rape, and other similar disgraceful behaviors will not be tolerated in this sect. Offenders will have their cultivation crippled and their disciple status renounced."

"Any degree of betrayal towards the sect will be punished with execution by beheading!"

Yuan spent almost the rest of his time playing to read and memorize the rule book that had a little over 100 pages.

Once it was time for dinner, Yuan logged off the game and waited for Yu Rou to return.

"Brother, are you still playing the game?" Yu Rou asked him after entering his room.

"I'm here, Yu Rou, and I would like to apologize for missing dinner and breakfast. I got too caught up with the disciple examination that I forgot about the time," Yuan said in an apologizing tone.

"Don't worry about it, brother. I'll forgive you since you appeared on the announcement again after learning an Ancient-rank skill. Tell me all about it when I come back with your dinner, okay?"

"Okay."

Yu Rou then left the room to prepare for his dinner.

Half an hour later, Yu Rou returned to his room, and Yuan began telling her about everything he's experienced in the examination, including his encounter with the Great One and its Legacy.

Chapter 119 - Outer Court Disciple

"Do you need more food, brother? You did miss last night's dinner and today's breakfast, after all." Yu Rou asked him after feeding him 3 bowls of soup.

"Thank you, and no, I don't," Yuan said.

"Okay, then I'll leave you alone for now."

After Yu Rou left the room, Yuan began cultivating by absorbing the spiritual energy in the room, and he would cultivate until the following morning when Yu Rou returned to his room with breakfast in her hands.

After breakfast, Yuan went back into Cultivation Online to check whether there were more people who'd passed the examination, but alas, there has yet to be another participant who'd passed the disciple examination besides him.

Seeing this, Yuan went back into his small room and reread the rule book one more time before logging off and spending the rest of his time cultivating in the real world.

Yuan would repeat this for the next four days until he could finally see other participants who had passed the examination appear at the gathering area, and he'd also managed to reach the 6th Spirit Apprentice during this time.

However, since there are still 3 days before the lecture, Yuan did not linger around and logged off to cultivate some more in the real world.

After waiting for a grand total of 7 days, once the disciple examination had officially ended and all of the participants who'd passed the exam gathered in the Dragon Essence Temple, Yuan finally emerged from his small room

and blended in with the crowd of new disciples while waiting for the lecture to begin.

There were a little over 300 disciples there, and considering how there were tens of thousands of people that had participated in the disciple examination from the beginning, it showed just how difficult the disciple examination truly was to the rest of the world.

Yuan looked around, and there were a few familiar faces that he recognized from the disciple examination, and one of them was Fairy Min, who'd displayed an impressive performance during the third examination and definitely one of the most prominent figures there.

Meanwhile, Fairy Min was also looking around with her small head turning left and right, seemingly trying to find a certain individual.

However, when she couldn't see this person she was looking for, a puzzled and surprised look appeared on her face.

'Where is that person with the black jade mask? Surely, he didn't fail the disciple examination, right? Not only was he a Spirit Warrior but he also had an unfathomable aura! There's no way someone like that could possibly fail the disciple examination!' Min Li pondered to herself when she could not see a man wearing a black jade mask in the crowd.

However, little did she know that Yuan was standing only a few feet away from her. Though, not only did Yuan change his appearance but he also consumed the Pill of Concealment that disguised his cultivation and aura, so it was only natural that Min Li did not recognize him.

After standing around for a few minutes, one of the sect elders appeared before them and said, "All of you new disciples, follow me to the lecture site!"

"Yes, Senior!"

The disciples then followed the sect elder like a group of ducklings.

Sometime later, they arrived at this large building and entered it. Once inside, they all took a seat and waited for the sect elder.

"First and foremost, allow me to congratulate you all on passing the disciple examination and becoming a disciple of the Dragon Essence Temple! Out of 54 thousand Cultivators that participated in the disciple examination, only 310 of you have managed to become a disciple! This is something you should be proud of!"

"For this lecture, I'll be talking mostly about a few sect rules and a few general things you need to know as a disciple of the Dragon Essence Temple!"

"Let me begin with your status as an Outer Court disciple."

"While you are a disciple of the great Dragon Essence Temple and you should feel proud, just remember that there is always someone better than you and that you are only an Outer Court disciple! If you see a Senior, be it a fellow disciple or a sect elder, be courteous and greet them! If a Senior asks you a question, answer them! In the cultivation world and not just the sect, respecting your Seniors will go a long way!"

"As an Outer Court disciple, do not expect any support from the sect when it comes to resources until you are an Inner Court disciple! If you want resources, work for them! The Dragon Essence Temple has over 100,000 disciples, which means resources are scarce and only those who are worthy will be supported! Although you may have become a disciple, you have not yet contributed to the sect, so do not expect the sect to hand out free food!"

"Now many of you should be wondering how you can obtain resources in the sect. Allow me to introduce you to the Contribution Hall, where you can spend your contribution points for resources and treasures alike. There are three different Contribution Halls, each located within their own court, so the Outer Court will have their own Contribution Hall whilst Inner Court will also have one."

"The difference between each Contribution Halls are the resources you can obtain from them, meaning you will be able to obtain more valuable

treasures in the Inner Court compared to the Outer Court, as this is a privilege for those who'd earned it and an incentive for you to climb higher in the sect and the cultivation world!"

The disciples swallowed nervously after hearing the sect elders' words.

"How does one obtain contribution points, Senior?" One of the disciples raised his hands to ask.

"There are many methods you can use to obtain contribution points. You do missions for the sect, you sell treasures you don't need, and you can even ask for them from your fellow disciples," said the sect elder.

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Chapter 120 - Their First Lecture

"What kind of missions do we have to do, Senior? And where do we accept these missions?" Another disciple asked after the sect elder stopped talking.

"You can find and accept all kinds of missions at the Mission Hall. Every mission inside the Mission Hall are requests from the people in the outside world, so you will obtain more than just contribution points from the sect, which is basically a little bonus from the sect," explained the sect elder.

"I should also let you know that as Outer Court disciples, you are obligated to complete at least one mission every three months, so quarterly. Failure to do so will result in punishment that is usually in the form of a fine, so you'll have to pay contribution points."

"There are a variety of missions with their own difficulties, so you can choose to do easy missions that require no skills like cleaning dishes for some restaurant or the more difficult missions that require you to hunt specific magical beasts for their materials. Of course, the harder the mission the more rewarding it will be at the end."

"However, don't chew more than you can bite, as there have been plenty of incidents that resulted in the deaths of disciples because the disciple arrogantly or ignorantly tried to challenge something they have no qualifications to even challenge."

Sometime later, the sect elder continued, "Okay, I think I have covered enough about contribution points. Now let's talk about what the sect of you as Outer Court disciples."

"First and foremost, you are not allowed to leave the sect without permission from the sect unless you are on a mission, and only Inner Court

disciples and above are allowed to leave the sect as they please. If you need to go somewhere, you must go to the Reception Hall and state your reason for leaving the sect. If the sect deems it reasonable, they will allow you to leave."

"If you are outside on a mission, you are not allowed to wander too much. If you leave the sect for too long without any accountability and for an unreasonably long amount of time, the sect will deem you as a deserter or dead and revoke your disciple status. This is mostly to prevent the Outer Court disciples from getting out of hand in the outside world. You guys are no longer mortals but Cultivators— disciples of an elite sect. Therefore, you must learn to separate yourself from the mortal world."

"If you encounter trouble with other Cultivators while you are outside, try to solve it peacefully, especially if the opposite party belongs to another elite sect. While it's very common for disciples from other sects to fight each other and our sect does not forbid fighting against others, you should know that there are people and places you cannot offend. Just keep that in mind because the Dragon Essence Temple is not invincible in this vast cultivation world."

After talking about a few more things regarding their status as Outer Court disciples, the sect elder began talking about a few rules for the sect.

"This can be found in your rule book, but I am still going to mention it because it still happens very often between disciples from all ranks. If you are in a disagreement with another disciple, before you duke it out in the middle of the sect and destroy the sect's property or accidentally hurt other disciples, find a sect elder to settle it for you. If that's not enough, you can challenge the other to an official fight in the arena, where you are free to fight each other to your heart's content. However, you are not allowed to kill your opponent."

"If the two of you truly hate each other to the point where you are not willing to exist in the same world, you can request for a deathmatch, and you will be able to kill your opponents during the deathmatch. However, once you agree to a deathmatch, the sect will no longer protect you no

matter what happens, and you will be at the mercy of your opponent and vice versa. Therefore, don't request for a deathmatch if you fear death."

After talking about a few more major rules that they should not break, the sect elders asked the disciples, "Do any of you have any questions for me before I let you all live your life as disciples?"

"Where do we live, sect elder?" One of the disciples raised her hands and asked.

"Your identification badge will show you the location of your living quarters, and it also acts as a key to the house so don't lose it. Furthermore, all Outer Court disciples are required to have roommates. Though, there will be some exceptions if you come from a renowned family."

The sect elder glanced at Min Li briefly before continuing, "Any more questions?"

"When can we start participating in lectures by the sect elders?" Another disciple asked.

"You can participate in them whenever you want. There will be at least 2 lectures a week from different sect elders at the Education Peak if you wish to listen to the lectures. If you're lucky, you might even get to see one of the higher-ranking sect elders there. Of course, they only appear once a year."

After spending a few more minutes answering the disciples' questions, the sect elder handed out another book to everybody there and said, "This is a guidebook that mentions all of the locations and buildings within the Dragon Essence Temple, and it answers most frequently asked questions. Even if you are looking for something specific, it should all be in there."

"Now that you have completed your first lecture, I shall let you all experience life as a disciple for the Dragon Essence Temple for yourselves."

"Thank you, Senior!"

All of the disciples then stood up and bowed to the sect elder before leaving the building with excitement and enthusiasm.

However, right as Yuan approached the door, the sect elder suddenly grabbed his arm and said, "Please stay here for a little longer, Disciple Yuan."

"O-Okay..." Yuan nodded with a startled look on his face.

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Chapter 121 - 1000 Contribution Points

"What's the matter, Senior?" Yuan asked him once the rest of the disciples had left the room.

"Grand Elder Xuan told me to hand you this Identification Token to you," said the sect elder as he handed Yuan another identity token.

"Identification Token? But I already have one," Yuan raised his eyebrows in a puzzled manner.

"Don't ask me, I am just following the Grand Elder's orders." The sect elder shrugged before walking away in a hurried manner, almost like he didn't want to stay there any longer.

'What kind of background does that disciple have that the Grand Elder would do something like this for him?' The sect elder wondered to himself after leaving the building, as this is his first time seeing a Grand Elder being involved with a mere Outer Court disciple, and he made a mental note to not offend a disciple named 'Yuan'.

Once the sect elder was gone, Yuan used his spiritual sense to activate the identification token, and inside his mind appeared the location of his living quarters. However, since he has 2 identification tokens, Yuan looked into both of them just in case there was a difference.

«Dragon Essence Temple Identification Bronze Token»

«Disciple Name: Yuan»

«Disciple Status: Outer Disciple»

«Living Quarters: Outer Court, Building #2,600»

«Mission Completed: 0»

«Contribution Points: 0»

«Offenses: 0»

—

«Dragon Essence Temple Identification Gold Token»

«Disciple Name: Yuan»

«Disciple Status: Outer Disciple»

«Living Quarters: Outer Court, Building #70»

«Mission Completed: 0»

«Contribution Points: 1,000»

«Offenses: 0»

"1,000 contribution points!" Although he didn't know its worth, Yuan was delighted to suddenly have 1,000 contribution points.

While Yuan didn't know this, the 1,000 contribution points was a portion of what Elder Xuan earned after winning the gamble regarding his results during the Tablet of Comprehension.

There were also two different buildings, so Yuan decided to take a look at the living quarter attached to the bronze token, which was building #2,600 within the Outer Sect.

After following the map in the token for about half an hour, Yuan arrived before this ordinary-looking building. Once he used the token to open the door, Yuan entered the house and looked around.

There were many rooms available inside the house— six to be exact, and five of them had their doors closed whilst the room near the end of the hallway was open.

Yuan walked to the end of the hallway to look inside the room, and as he'd expected, the room was completely empty.

"This isn't much better than the guest room I'd stayed 7 days in..." Yuan was baffled when he saw how the bed alone took up half of the entire room.

However, at least this bed has a mattress on it. The quality of the mattress was another matter, though, as it was tough and uncomfortable.

Of course, Yuan was unaware that there was a good reason as to why an elite sect such as the Dragon Essence Temple would have such poor living conditions, as having a comfortable bed or environment would only encourage laziness, hence why the sect is making it difficult for the disciples to relax and be lazy.

"Hopefully the other building is slightly better," Yuan sighed before walking out of the room.

"Hm? Are you a new disciple?"

One of the other 5 closed rooms there suddenly opened, and a young man around Yuan's age walked out of the room at the same time Yuan walked out of his room.

"Yes, I am," Yuan nodded.

"I see. Well, welcome to building #2,600. My surname is Shen, and I became a disciple here not long ago— three months ago." The disciple extended his hand for a handshake.

Yuan accepted the handshake and introduced himself, "My name is Yuan, and I just passed the disciple examination."

"Oh? Did you perhaps manage to see Fairy Min during the examination?" Disciple Shen suddenly changed topics.

"Fairy Min? Oh, yes, I saw her achieving 50 steps during the third examination," Yuan nodded.

"Damn! You lucky bastard managed to witness Fairy Min's glory! I wish I was there! If only I didn't decide to participate in the previous examination!" Disciple Shen exclaimed, dumbfounding Yuan.

"Is she that famous?" Yuan asked him afterward.

"Of course! Don't tell me you've not heard of her family—the Min Family?! They are one of the Seven Legacy Families!" Disciple Shen spoke with an admiring look on his face.

"Legacy Families? What are those?" Yuan raised his eyebrows, as this is his first time hearing such a thing.

"You must have come from a backwater place if you don't even know of the Seven Legacy Families! They are the most influential and powerful families within the Lower Heavens. However, the most special thing about the Legacy Families is their history and background, as they are merely branches of a much larger power in the upper heavens!"

"Why would they do that?" Yuan asked.

"To train their descendants, obviously. If their descendants, which is Fairy Min in this case, fulfill her family's legacy, she will receive immense status and power once she returns to her family in the upper heavens. And for a family to have their own Legacy, the Min Family must be immensely powerful even in the upper heavens."

"Wow, the cultivation world is much more complicated than I thought..." Yuan mumbled in a low voice.

"Anyways, I'm going to see if there are any easy missions I can partake in at the Mission Hall. I'll see you around, fellow disciple." Disciple Shen waved at him before leaving the building.

Meanwhile, Yuan followed the map in his second identification token and went to his second living quarters.

"This is..."

However, before he even reached his building, Yuan was quickly dumbfounded by the luxurious buildings located in this area, feeling as though he'd accidentally entered the wrong neighborhood that was meant for the wealthy and powerful disciples.

"Am I going to live here?" Yuan wondered as he looked for building #70.

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Chapter 122 - You Don't Belong Here!

Chapter 122 - You Don't Belong Here!

After walking around for a few minutes and following the building numbers, Yuan finally arrived at building #70, and it was a large building with two floors.

"This is definitely better than the previous house, but this might be a little too much of an improvement..." Yuan stood in front of the building for a minute to admire the aesthetics of these buildings.

"Congratulations on passing the disciple examination, Fairy Min! Of course, we knew you'd pass the examination before you even took it!"

"Forget about passing the examination! Fairy Min had achieved 50 steps in the silver pond! It has been seven years since someone managed such a feat! I'm sure the Min Family will be ecstatic once they hear of this!"

"How would you like to celebrate this occasion? Should we have a feast at the Dragon Pavilion later?"

"That sounds like a great idea! What do you think, Fairy Min? The food's on us!"

When Yuan overheard this conversation, he turned around and noticed a large group of disciples walking with a beautiful young lady— Fairy Min. However, these disciples were not wearing the Outer Court's uniform.

The Outer Court disciples are given plain white clothes as their uniforms, whilst the Inner Court disciples get to wear colorful blue and green uniforms, and that was what the majority of the disciples following Fairy Min were wearing.

"Hm?"

Fairy Min suddenly stopped walking when she noticed Yuan standing not far away, and the other disciples also stopped to look at Yuan.

"Who's that guy? I don't recognize his face." One of the disciples there said.

"I don't either."

"Then what's he doing in this area?"

"Looking at his uniform, he's only an Outer Court disciple. Besides Fairy Min who's from one of the Seven Legacy Families and the top-ranking disciples, how many Outer Court disciples get to live here? He must have gotten lost or something."

While the disciples mumbled to each other trying to figure out Yuan's ability, Fairy Min narrowed her eyes and stared at Yuan with a pondering expression.

'Why does it feel like I have seen him somewhere before?' Fairy Min thought to herself.

She was confident that she has never seen Yuan before, yet she couldn't shake off this feeling that she has seen him somewhere before, and it was very recently, too.

However, her thoughts were quickly interrupted by the disciples around her.

"Hey! You there! What do you think you are doing in this place?! This is not a place where ordinary Outer Court disciples can just wander around! Get out of here!"

Hearing the disciple's question, Yuan responded in a calm voice, "But I live here."

"What? You live here?"

The disciples exchanged glances with each other before one of them asked, "Are you a new disciple? Which family do you belong in?"

"Yes, I just passed the disciple examination, and I don't belong to any family," Yuan said.

"How can a nobody— a new disciple, no less, be assigned a house in this area meant for the privileged? Did the sect elders make a mistake somewhere and accidentally gave him the wrong house?" One of the disciples spoke his thoughts out loud.

"That must be a case! Although it's uncommon, mistakes like this are bound to happen every so often."

The other disciples quickly agreed with the disciple who just spoke.

"You heard us! There must have been a mistake that allowed you to get a house in this place! Return to the sect elder who handed you your identification token and tell him about the mistake! If you want to live in this area, you must either be ranked top 10 in the disciple ranking for the Outer Court disciples' ranking or come from a prominent family like Fairy Min here! Hurry up and get out of here! You're ruining our moods!"

"..." Yuan was speechless. These disciples were essentially telling him to tell Grand Elder Xuan that he'd made a mistake!

After a moment of silence, Yuan said to the disciples, "I don't think there were any mistakes. Now if you'll excuse me, I would like to settle down in my new home."

Yuan turned around and began walking towards his house.

The disciples were dumbfounded by Yuan's daring response.

Meanwhile, the disciple who just told Yuan to

"The audacity! Do you know who you are talking to? I am an Inner Court disciple! Since you are a new disciple, I won't blame you too much! However, for you to claim that you live here despite what we told you whilst being a nobody— that's spitting in the faces of everyone that lives here, which includes Fairy Min! Therefore, I am going to need you to get

on your knees and apologize to her!" The Inner Court disciple stepped forward and pointed at Yuan with an overbearing aura.

"..."

Yuan was speechless. It hasn't even been half a day since he got to live life as a disciple and he's already in an awkward situation with other disciples.

"Do you hear me?! Get on your knees and apologize to Fairy Min!" The Inner Court disciple repeated, seemingly adamant about making Yuan apologize.

However, despite his humble nature, Yuan was not the type to apologize for something he didn't do, especially if the other party was being unreasonable!

"Why should I apologize? If there has truly been a mistake with my lodging, I will leave. However, you did not hand me my identification token so you don't know that, yet you are telling me to apologize. Don't be unreasonable," Yuan said to the disciples with a slight frown on his face.

And he continued, "If you want to continue arguing that I don't belong here, you can bring a sect elder here and we can settle it that way. Until then, I am going to stay here. Goodbye."

Yuan turned around and opened the door with the identification token before walking inside.

"Get back here, you little bastard!"

Yuan heard an angry shout as he entered the building, but he ignored it and closed the door, leaving the people outside completely speechless, as this is the first time they have encountered an Outer Court disciple like Yuan.

Chapter 123 - Returning With A Sect Elder

"That damn disrespectful little brat! He's only a mere Outer Court disciple who'd just passed the disciple examination! How dare he disrespect and defy so many Inner Court disciples?! Who the fuck does he think he is?!"

The Inner Court disciple that Yuan ignored stomped the floor angrily, feeling his blood boiling from anger, as this is his first time being treated in such a fashion ever since he became an Inner Court disciple, and to make things even worse, it'd happened right in front of Fairy Min—the woman he admired!

"Right? I have never seen a disciple that disobedient towards his Seniors! There must be something wrong with that disciple's head! He was probably dropped on the head when he was young!"

"Since he wants to play, I'll play with him! He thinks everything will be okay if a sect elder is involved! I'll show him just how mistaken he is! A mere Outer Court disciple dares to defy me? Courting death!" The Inner Court disciple sneered.

"Anyway, I will apologize for that disciple's crime! Please don't mind him — I'll have him kicked out of this place as soon as possible! After all, only privileged geniuses such as yourself are worthy of living here!" The Inner Court disciple said to her with a smile on his face.

"You can do whatever you want," Fairy Min spoke for the first time, yet her voice was without emotions, almost like she was not interested in the situation or the disciples following her.

"Anyway, what do you think about our offer, Fairy Min? Do you want to celebrate with us at the Dragon Pavilion later today?" The other disciples continued to ask her.

"No thank you, I am busy with other things," Fairy Min said to them before she began walking again.

A few moments later, Fairy Min stopped in front of a certain building and began walking towards the door.

When the disciples following her saw the building she was approaching, their faces dropped and their complexions paled.

"What! That's ridiculous! Fairy Min's living quarters is actually right beside that little bastard?!" One of the disciples exclaimed out loud.

Indeed, Fairy Min was assigned to building #69, making Yuan her neighbor.

"Hmph! He won't be living there for long!"

"That's right! It'll be a miracle if he's still living in that building after today!"

"I would love to break that door down and drag that little fucker out here and give him a good beating, but this is a special place that even we, Inner Court disciples, cannot intrude!"

"Enough talking! I am going to get a sect elder to force that bastard out here and kowtow to us! I am going to let him know the disparity between an Outer Court disciple and an Inner Court disciple today!"

"Hahaha! I'll stay here to make sure he doesn't go anywhere or try to run away! It's too late even if he's realized his mistakes! After today, he won't ever dare to disrespect another Inner Court disciple again!"

The Inner Court disciple nodded before leaving the scene to look for a sect elder whilst the other disciples lingered around the area, patiently waiting for him to return in anticipation for some good drama.

Meanwhile, inside her house, after closing the door, Fairy Min sighed out loud, "What a bunch of annoying and shameless individuals. I don't even know them, yet they're treating me as though we're best friends because of my background."

The Inner Court disciples and other disciples that had been following Fairy Min were complete strangers that decided to follow her on their own will, but such a scene was not uncommon for her. As the young lady of the Min Family, there are always people looking for an opportunity to form a connection with her because of her powerful family, and it has been that way since she was young. However, she quickly learned that ignoring them and treating them as though they are invisible was the best solution, hence why she didn't tell them to go away.

"Though, I do feel sorry for that Outer Court disciple. He has offended so many Inner Court disciples on his first day as a new disciple in this sect, and I share some blame for his situation, as I was the one who brought them with me even if it wasn't intentional."

Fairy Min sighed. However, it was too late to save the Outer Court disciple after everything that had happened, as the hole he'd dug himself was simply too deep.

Even if a sect elder solves the problem with the lodging, the Inner Court disciples will surely continue to make that Outer Court disciple's life a living hell for offending them.

Furthermore, as a member of a Legacy Family, she cannot meddle with others' affairs too much as it could reflect on her family as a whole, something she cannot afford to happen even if she has to turn a blind eye to some unfortunate young man.

Sometime later, the Inner Court disciple returned to Yuan's living quarters with a sect elder by his side.

"Heavens! That Qiao Kang actually brought back Elder Yao who is known for being especially harsh on Outer Court disciples while being the

complete opposite for Inner Court disciples! That Outer Court disciple is truly unlucky to have to deal with some like Elder Yao!"

"Hahaha! Forget about staying in that building, that Outer Court disciple probably won't be able to stay in the sect after this!"

"Greetings, Elder Yao!"

The disciples there greeted him when he got close.

"Where is the Outer Court disciple that dares to disrespect Inner Court disciples and act almighty before the Young Lady of the Min Family?!" Elder Yao spoke loudly.

A few moments later, the Inner Court disciple known as Qiao Kang stopped in front of building #70 and said to Elder Yao while pointing at the building — "This is the place, Elder Yao! He's inside!"

Elder Yao nodded with an angry frown on his face, "Good! I will make this insolent brat regret being born today! Step back!"

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Chapter 124 - Lowering Their Heads

The disciples there immediately moved to make a path for Elder Yao, who approached Yuan's living quarters with heavy steps.

"I have never seen Elder Yao so angry before! That Outer Court disciple is dead! He's definitely going to regret acting all tough after meeting Elder Yao!"

The disciples there watched with anticipation as Elder Yao stepped on the doorsteps in front of Yuan's building.

BANG! BANG! BANG!

Elder Yao knocked on the door with force before shouting in a vicious voice, "This is Elder Yao from the 3rd Disciplinary Squad! Get your ass out here right this instance and identify yourself, Outer Court disciple!"

The disciples standing not far away felt their hearts tremble after hearing Elder Yao's loud voice, and even though they were not the ones in trouble, it still struck fear into their minds.

BANG! BANG! BANG!

"Get out here right this instance! Or do I have to force myself inside instead, Outer Court disciple?!" Elder Yao knocked on the door again when nobody answered the door after 5 short seconds.

After a few more seconds, the door finally opened, and Yuan appeared before them once again with a calm expression on his face.

"So you're the Outer Court disciple who claimed that you belong in this area? If that's the case, how come I don't recognize your face at all, huh?" Elder Yan narrowed his eyes at Yuan's face.

"Isn't it normal that you won't recognize everyone in the world?" Yuan asked with his eyebrows raised.

Elder Yao looked at him with a face of disbelief. "You actually dare talk back to me, a sect elder? Looks like Disciple Qiao was telling the truth when he called you a disrespectful little brat! Kneel before me right now and apologize!"

Yuan was speechless. He frowned a moment later and said, "Aren't you here to see whether assigning this house to me is a mistake or not? Yet you started yelling at me the moment you arrived, acting like I am in the wrong. I respect my Seniors, but I also know an unreasonable person when I see one!"

"Y-You little brat! You really think you deserve to live here, huh?! You are just a nobody! A mere Outer Court disciple who'd just passed the disciple examination!"

Elder Yao roared at Yuan, and he continued, "And you dare to claim that you are worthy enough to live beside someone like the Young Lady of the Min Family?! Do you have no shame?! Even I wouldn't dare to live beside the Min Family if you paid me!"

"If it wasn't a mistake that you got assigned this building, I will freaking eat my shoes before every single Outer Court disciple in this sect!"

Hearing Elder Yao's words, Yuan became speechless. Is this sect elder really going to eat his own shoes? He cannot imagine it.

"Since you don't want to leave this place, I have no choice but to force you out with my authority as a sect elder of the Disciplinary Hall!"

And before Yuan could even respond, Elder Yao suddenly moved to grab him by the collar before throwing him into the air and forcing him out of

the house.

"Whoa!"

Yuan landed a few meters away with a startled look on his face.

"Now hand me your identification token! Or do I have to take it with force as well?!" Elder Yao approached him with an overbearing and oppressing aura.

However, since Elder Yao was only a fourth level Spirit Warrior Cultivator, Yuan didn't feel any pressure from him.

'Should I just use the Absolute Authority the Sect Master gave me to deal with this situation?' Yuan pondered as Elder Yao got closer to him. After all, even a naive little boy would be able to tell by now that Elder Yao was not the reasonable type and that no matter what Yuan says to him at this point, he would only be wasting his breath.

'I wanted to settle this as peacefully as possible, but alas...'

Yuan sighed inwardly as he reached into his Spatial Ring for the Absolute Authority. However, before Yuan could even take it out, a loud sigh suddenly resounded and echoed in the area.

"I knew you would run into some trouble when I decided to give you one of the buildings in this place, but I didn't think it'd come so soon and in such a manner, too." A calm voice followed after the sigh ended.

"T-This voice is..." Elder Yao immediately stopped walking after hearing this profound voice, and his body trembled in shock.

However, the other disciples did not recognize the identity behind this mysterious voice and were completely puzzled.

Meanwhile, inside one of the rooms in building #69, Fairy Min, who had been watching the situation from the beginning by peeking through the closed curtains from the windows, mumbled in a surprised voice, "This voice belongs to Grand Elder Xuan! Why did he show up here? And

judging by his words, it seems like he was the one who allowed that Outer Court disciple to live here! Just who is that young man?!"

"Elder Yao, I am greatly disappointed by your performance today. As a sect elder of the Disciplinary Hall, I had expected you to handle this situation professionally and properly, yet you were blinded by anger and acted unfitting of your status, even treating my granddaughter's friend in such an aggressive manner... I don't know what I should do with you." Elder Xuan's voice continued to speak, lecturing Elder Yao who was sweating profusely at this moment.

Elder Yao quickly kneeled on the ground and lowered his head before speaking in a pleading voice, "This disciple was wrong and has done something inexcusable! Please punish this disciple as you see fit, Grand Elder!"

"GRAND ELDER?!" The disciples watching the scene were greatly shocked after hearing Elder Yao's voice, and they finally realized the identity behind the voice.

After realizing this fact, they also kneeled on the ground with their heads lowered and their backs soaked in cold sweats, wondering to themselves why the hell would a Grand Elder suddenly become involved with their situation!

Chapter 125 - Two Choices

Seeing Elder Yao and the disciples lowering their heads, Elder Xuan spoke without revealing his presence, "If you think lowering your heads will solve everything, the world would not be this chaotic and dangerous."

"Please forgive us, Grand Elder! We were wrong! We didn't know this Outer Court disciple was assigned to this place by you!" Qiao Kang suddenly said.

"Did I ask for your input, disciple?" Elder Xuan responded in a nonchalant voice, immediately shutting the Qiao Kang up.

Elder Xuan continued a moment later, "Every disciple here will be punished with 1 month of confinement within the Caves of Repentance."

"As for you, Elder Yao... Since you belong to the Disciplinary Hall, I shall let your leader decide your punishment. And before you leave, I want you to remember what comes out of my mouth next— What happened here today did not happen at all, do you understand me? I was never here, and you have never met the Outer Court disciple. This applies to the disciples, too."

"If I hear even a single disciple that is not here right now speaking about what happened here today, you can expect another visit from me, and I will be there in person at that time."

"We understand, Grand Elder! We will forget about what happened today!"

Elder Yao and the disciples responded in a fearful voice.

"Good. Now get out of my sight!" Elder Xuan's voice boomed within the disciples' and Elder Yao's head, nearly knocking them unconscious with his

powerful voice.

The next second, once they could stand again, the disciples and Elder Yao ran away like a bunch of scared rabbits before a tiger.

Once they were all gone, Elder Xuan spoke again, "Are you okay, Disciple Yuan? I apologize for that just now. While it's common for disciples to argue with each other, it's inexcusable for a sect elder to bully a disciple."

"Don't worry about it, Senior Xuan. It's only natural that there'd be a couple of bad apples no matter where you are," Yuan said with a calm smile on his face.

"You have handled this situation much better than I would've if I was still a disciple, and I thank you for that. Most people quickly result to violence when they come to a disagreement, and that is a trait many Cultivators have because we are vicious and brutal in nature. Anyway, I must return to my own business now. If you ever encounter another similar situation, it's okay to scare them a little with your powers as long as you don't kill them. This is just how the cultivation world works, as intimidation works better than actual violence in most cases."

"However, if a sect elder is involved like today, it's best if you immediately contact one of us to help you. Although we won't show ourselves, we'll definitely keep you safe."

"Intimidation over violence... I will keep that in mind, Senior Xuan! Thank you very much for helping me today!" Yuan bowed towards the sky, feeling as though he'd learned something important today.

"Don't even mention it.... Hahaha..." Elder Xuan's voice sounded as though it was getting further away, dumbfounding Yuan.

Once Yuan could no longer hear Elder Xuan's laughing voice, Yuan returned to his room and sat on the large, comfortable bed before taking out the guide book and reading through it as he was doing before being interrupted by Elder Yao and the others.

Meanwhile, inside Fairy Min's room, the beautiful young lady remained standing by the window with a dazed look on her face.

"Disciple Yuan? I don't recognize this name at all. Just who is he? Which family did he come from? And what kind of connection does he have with the Grand Elder? Although the Grand Elder said that the Outer Court disciple was his granddaughter's friend, their conversation sounded like they were pretty close friends themselves!" Min Li mumbled to herself in a dumbfounded voice, feeling her interest slightly piqued by him.

Sometime later, at the Disciplinary Hall, Elder Yao entered Bai Ling's room after being summoned by him.

"Greetings, Leader Bai!" Elder Yao bowed to him with respect and his back soaked in sweat.

"Do you know why I called you here?" Bai Ling ignored his greetings and asked him with a calm voice.

"Yes, I do!" Elder Yao responded after a brief moment of silence.

"Good, then this will make things much easier for the both of us." Bai Ling then stood up from his chair and walked to the window before staring outside with a seemingly dazed look on his face.

"Do you have any idea what you've done today, Elder Yao?" Bai Ling asked him a moment later.

"No, I do not, Leader Bai!" Elder Yao quickly responded.

"At least you're honest," Bai Ling nodded, and he continued, "That Outer Court disciple... you may not know him now, but I can guarantee you that you will know him in the near future—and I am willing to bet my position as Leader of the Disciplinary Hall that you will regret what you've done today."

Elder Yao looked at him with a surprised look, and he said, "Please enlighten this ignorant one, Leader Bai! Just who is that Outer Court

disciple and why did Grand Elder Xuan protect him?"

"..."

However, Bai Ling did not respond to his question and continued to speak as though he never heard it, "I will give you two choices, Elder Yao. For your offenses today, I can either let the Sect Master know about this incident so he can punish you himself, or you can give a lecture to the disciples at the Education Peak and eat your shoes before every disciple there afterward. It's your decision."

"W-What did you just say?!" Elder Yao cried out loud with pure disbelief on his face

Why on earth would Bai Ling involve the Sect Master over a mere Outer Court disciple?! It was not as though he'd killed this disciple! This is ridiculous! How can they treat a sect elder like him because of a single Outer Court disciple?! None of this made any sense!

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Chapter 126 - A Massive Crowd At The Education Peak

"Did I stutter, Elder Yao? Perhaps I did, so allow me to rephrase myself," Bai Ling then spoke slower but in a much louder and clearer voice, "Either I let the Sect Master know about your mistakes today, or you eat your own shoes before the disciples at the Education Peak at the end of your lecture."

"I won't do something as unreasonable as kicking you out of the sect or anything like that so consider yourself lucky that you're getting off so lightly."

'Mother fucker! You dare call this a light punishment?! Telling me to eat my shoes in front of the disciples is worse than being kicked out of the sect! At least I would still have my dignity left for the latter punishment!' Elder Yao cursed at Bai Ling inwardly, as he didn't dare to utter such words for real.

"I know what you're thinking, Elder Yao. After all, you have worked with me for over 10 years now. However, you have no idea how much trouble you are actually in, and I don't blame you for that. That's why I am letting you know right now that you should eat your own shoes before I let the Sect Master know, as he might really kick you out of the sect if he finds out what had transpired today." Bai Ling said to Elder Yao while knowing very well that Long Yijun will definitely hear about this incident sooner or later.

"Is this situation really that serious? I would understand it if that Outer Court disciple belonged to one of the Seven Legacy Families but he's clearly not!" Elder Yao spoke a moment later with a relentless expression on his face.

"Don't even bother asking me about that Outer Court disciple's identity because I won't say anything unless you don't mind dying afterward." Bai Ling looked at Elder Yao with his eyes narrowed and emitting faint killing intent.

Elder Yao swallowed nervously after seeing this, and after a moment of silence, he sighed, "Very well... I shall eat my own shoes in front of the disciples..."

"Good choice. You may leave now." Bai Ling said to him.

Elder Yao nodded and left the room, but he didn't forget to bow to Bai Ling before leaving as that was how much he'd respected the leader of the Disciplinary Hall.

'Not just Grand Elder Xuan but even Leader Bai and possibly the Sect Master is protecting that Outer Court disciple! What on earth is that brat's identity? If he doesn't belong to the Seven Legacy Families then he could only come from the Four Ancient Families!' Elder Yao pondered to himself as he returned home to prepare for the lecture.

Later the same day, Elder Yao walked to the Education Peak with a solemn expression on his face.

'Damn! I shouldn't have run my mouth at that time! No! That fucking brat Qiao Kang is the root of this! If he didn't come to me, I would've never met that damn Outer Court disciple and offended the Grand Elder and Leader Bai! I'll fucking kill him once he comes out of confinement!' Elder Yao cursed inwardly as he approached the Education Peak, where thousands of disciples could be seen walking about.

The Education Peak is where disciples gather to partake in lectures from sect elders. However, not only sect elders gave lectures there, as disciples are also able to give their own lectures if they were approved by the sect, so there would always be lectures for disciples to participate.

Of course, the Education Peak is the most populated when a sect elder decides to give a lecture, as they are often the most knowledgeable and

experienced in the sect, hence why when Elder Yao suddenly showed up at the Education Peak, the disciples there immediately began following him.

"Isn't that Elder Yao? It's been a while since I have been to one of his lectures!"

"Me, too! The last time he'd given a lecture was nearly 3 years ago! I heard that over a dozen Outer Court disciples who'd listened to his lecture managed to become an Inner Court disciple within the same year!"

"Really? Then I must listen to his lecture today even if the heavens fall!"

"We still don't know whether Elder Yao is really giving a lecture today or he's just visiting since there was no prior notice! Most sect elders announce their lectures a least a week beforehand!"

"He's not telling us that he's not giving a lecture even though there are so many of us clearly following him. Surely, he intends on giving a lecture today!"

"I hope you're right! I have been dying to attend a lecture given by Elder Yao!"

The hype between the disciples grew as they followed Elder Yao to one of the many empty areas designed for public lectures.

Sometime later, Elder Yao settled down in one of these areas and stood at the spot meant for the lecturers.

"See! He's really giving a lecture today! Looks like we lucked out today by coming here and witnessing it by chance!"

"Hahaha! You are so damn right!"

"Hey, is it just me or does Elder Yao seem a bit off today? He looks kind of sick." One of the disciples there noticed Elder Yao's pale complexion and mumbled to the disciples around him.

"You're right. He looks like he hasn't slept or eaten in a week or something."

Meanwhile, Elder Yao scanned the massive crowd that had gathered for his 'lecture' with his back soaked in cold sweats.

'Fuck... why are there so many disciples at the Education Peak today when there are no sect elders giving lectures? If I don't become a laughing stock after today, I'll eat my damn shoes again!' Elder Yao cursed inwardly, feeling the urge to cry out loud.

There were at least 3 thousand disciples gathered there, and every single one of them was staring at Elder Yao with anticipation in their gazes, looking like a bunch of children before their idol, but alas, little did they expect that they were merely participating in a clown show disguised as a lecture!

Chapter 127 - Eating His Own Shoes

"Ahem!" Elder Yao suddenly cleared his throat loudly, trying to relieve some of his anxiety, but alas, it barely helped him keep calm.

"W-Welcome, disciples. F-For today's lecture... I will be... giving a lecture... on..." Elder Yao spoke in a trembling voice, feeling as though he was a child with stage fright while standing on the stage for the first time, and he could barely complete a full sentence without stuttering.

When the disciples saw this, they silently looked at each other with their eyebrows raised and their gazes full of questions. Why was Elder Yao acting so weird? It seemed like he was on the verge of a breakdown from the disciples' view.

"Are you okay, Elder Yao? You don't look so good." One of the Inner Court disciples there decided to ask him.

"I am fine... Just feeling a little under the weather..." Elder Yao responded a moment later.

'Feeling under the weather?' The disciples became even more puzzled after hearing such words.

Why would a sect elder willingly give a lecture when he's sick? Furthermore, can Cultivators even feel 'under the weather'? Clearly, it was something else that was bothering him, but these disciples didn't dare to probe any further and accepted his lie as the truth, as they didn't dare to offend Elder Yao who was known for being a ruthless sect elder.

The disciples then patiently waited for Elder Yao to get himself together before continuing with the lecture.

A few minutes later, once Elder Yao calmed down enough, he began giving the lecture, and it was about random things that made no sense for a lecture, but the nervousness and uncertainty in his voice did not go away and remained for the rest of the lecture. In fact, his voice only became weirder and harder to listen as the lecture went on.

The disciples participating in the lecture were greatly baffled by the bizarre situation with some of them even thinking that they were being pranked by Elder Yao. After all, no sane sect elder would call this mess a 'lecture', as it was more of a babbling session with the topic constantly changing abruptly.

However, none of the disciples spoke up nor complained regardless of the unusual situation, nor did any of them decide to suddenly leave the lecture abruptly, as they were still afraid of offending Elder Yao.

The 'lecture' by Elder Yao lasted for an entire hour, but for the disciples, it felt like they were being punished for an eternity.

'Fuck! Why am I wasting my time here?! I could've been listening to Fairy Ling's lecture by now!'

'What the heck is Elder Yao doing? Has he lost his mind? I want my precious time back!'

"Damn it! I want to leave now but what if I offend him? I have heard about his reputation and I don't want to be the first one to leave!"

The disciples there cursed inwardly, and most of them silently hoped for another disciple to leave first so they can follow! But alas, because all of them were thinking the same thing and waited for someone else to act, none of them left and stayed for the entire lecture!

"This is the end of my lecture..." Elder Yao said to the disciples at the end of the lecture.

However, he wasn't completely finished there, as he still had one more thing to do.

And just as the disciples there sighed in relief inwardly that the lecture was finally finished and prepared to leave, Elder Yao suddenly removed his shoes and began doing the unthinkable— putting it in his mouth and chewing it as though it was food!

"What the fuck?" One of the disciples there couldn't hold back his voice and spoke in a surprised voice after witnessing Elder Yao eating his own shoes.

In fact, every disciple there was staring at Elder Yao with a gawking expression at this moment, looking like they were witnessing the impossible.

And because Elder Yao was a Cultivator at the Spirit Warrior realm, he was able to bite through the shoe with his raw strength and chew on it.

After chewing on his own shoes for a few seconds with a disgusted expression that he could not hide on his face, Elder Yao swallowed it.

"Urg!"

Elder Yao almost puked after feeling the shoe enter his stomach, but alas, he resisted his urges and continued eating the rest of the shoe.

The disciples that were prepared to leave the place as quickly as possible no longer moved, and they all stood there with dazed faces as they watched Elder Yao eat his shoe with a suffering expression on his face.

A few gruesome minutes later, Elder Yao finished eating his shoe. However, he did not stop there and proceeded to remove his second shoe and began eating that too.

Sometime later, Elder Yao finished eating his other shoe.

Once he swallowed the last bit of his shoe, Elder Yao glared at the disciples there before walking away in silence and quickly disappearing from the

scene while barefooted, leaving the disciples in wonder as he'd left without giving any explanation.

When Elder Yao's figure left the Education Peak, all of the disciples there finally spoke again, immediately creating an uproar within the sect, and as one would've expected from such a bizarre situation, news of Elder Yao eating his own shoes after an embarrassing 'lecture' spread throughout the entire sect like wildfire, shocking every disciple and sect elder that heard it.

Meanwhile, at the Disciplinary Hall, Elder Yao stood before Bai Ling once again, but he was barefooted this time since he came straight to this place after leaving the Education Peak.

"I hope you've learned your lesson today, Elder Yao. Just because they are Outer Court disciples doesn't mean you can walk all over them like they're ants, as you'll one day step on the wrong ant and face its wrath like today," Bai Ling said to him with a nonchalant expression on his face.

"Thank you for this lesson, Leader Bai..." Elder Yao bowed to him before leaving the room with a blank look on his face, looking like he had died inside.

Chapter 128 - What Does New Disciples Normally Do?

At the Sect Master's Pagoda, Long Yijun listened to Elder Xuan briefing him about the situation with a serious expression on his face.

"Elder Yao and Disciple Yuan... what a pain in the ass..." Long Yijun rubbed his eyes with an exhausted look afterward.

"Are you going to do anything about this, Sect Master?" Elder Xuan asked him.

After a moment of silence, Long Yijun shook his head and said, "As much as I want to beat Elder Yao for what he did to Disciple Yuan, Elder Bai has already dealt with the situation and punished Elder Yao for his behavior. I appointed Elder Bai the leader of the Disciplinary Hall for a reason, and I don't like beating a dead horse so I am not going to step in this time."

"I understand," Elder Xuan nodded.

Meanwhile, back at building #70, Yuan closed the guidebook after reading through the entire thing.

"Wow, there are so many exciting places in the Dragon Essence Temple! I will definitely visit all of them when I get the chance, especially this Dragon Pavilion restaurant that's meant for Cultivators! I wonder how it differs from the restaurants outside?" Yuan mumbled to himself.

"Hmm, it's still too early for dinner, so I'll look around for now." Yuan then got off the bed and made his way outside.

"What should I do now that I am a disciple? What do disciples normally do?" Yuan pondered to himself as he went outside.

"Disciple Yuan! Please wait for a second!"

Yuan stopped walking when a clear voice resounded from behind him, causing him to turn around to see who'd just spoken.

"You are..."

To his surprise, Fairy Min was outside of her house and appeared to be the one who'd just called for him.

"How did you know my name?" Yuan asked her with raised eyebrows, as he doesn't recall ever introducing himself to her or any of the disciples from the disciple examination.

"I accidentally overheard your conversation with Grand Elder Xuan and learned of your name. Don't worry, I won't tell anyone about your relationship with the Grand Elder or what happened today." Fairy Min spoke as she approached him.

"I see... thank you?" Yuan responded with a puzzled look on his face, as he wasn't sure what she was up to.

'Is she going to try and kick me out, too?' Yuan wondered to himself.

Once Fairy Min was standing a few steps away from him, she spoke, "I haven't introduced myself. I am Min Li from one of the Seven Legacy Family. And I would like to apologize for what happened today. Even though I didn't know them, I should've stepped in and told them to stop."

"Huh? You didn't know them?" Yuan looked at her with wide eyes. Then why were they following her around like they were a group of close friends? Hell, they even spoke to her as though they have known each other for years!

"I know this may sound like I am bragging but when you're coming from a family as prestigious as one of the Seven Legacy Families, there are always

people like those disciples from before following me around hoping they'd benefit from me or my family, and it's better for me to act like they are not there most of the time, hence why I didn't tell them to go away," Min Li explained to him after seeing his puzzled face.

"Of course, I am sure you understand my feelings since you also appear to be from a powerful family."

"Uhh..." Yuan scratched his head with an awkward atmosphere around him, and he said, "I'm not from any powerful nor prestigious family, though."

"Huh? You're not?" Min Li looked at him with her eyes widened slightly from surprise.

If he doesn't come from a powerful or influential family, why did Grand Elder Xuan protect him from Elder Yao and the Inner Court disciples, much less give him a building in this area meant for the privileged. Surely, there must be something special about him!

'So you want to hide your real identity, huh? I will find out the truth sooner or later!' Min Li thought to herself whilst trying her best to remain calm on the outside.

"By the way, where are you going now?" Min Li suddenly asked him.

"I honestly don't know myself. I'll probably just walk around until I see something interesting," Yuan shrugged.

"Walk around until you see something interesting?" Min Li raised her neat and slender eyebrows in a puzzled manner. Why does it sound like he's going to take a stroll around the sect like he's at the park? Does he have that much free time on his hands? Even though he'd just become a disciple? After all, most people would be either cultivating or doing something more productive as a new disciple.

"Do you have any suggestions? What do disciples normally do when they just joined a sect?" Yuan suddenly asked her.

"Uhh... They either go to the Profound Pavilion to learn new techniques or they go to the Education Peak for lectures. However, seeing that you are at the seventh level Spirit Apprentice already, you should go to the Profound Pavilion." Min Li gave her suggestions to him.

"Profound Pavilion, huh?" Yuan immediately began pondering.

'I already have three sword techniques, but I only have one dagger technique, and it's not really even a dagger technique as it's meant for cooking instead. Maybe I should see if the Profound Pavilion will have a good dagger technique that'll go well with the Starry Abyss...'

After pondering for a minute, Yuan has decided to go to the Profound Pavilion to search for a new dagger technique.

"Thank you, Disciple Min, for your guidance," Yuan said to her with a bright smile, and he continued, "And you don't worry about what happened previously since I can tell that you're not a bad person."

"..."

Min Li looked at his handsome smile with a slightly dazed look on her pretty face, and when she noticed that Yuan was walking away, she unconsciously shouted, "Wait! I'll come with you, too!"

Chapter 129 - Profound Pavilion

"You want to come with me? Why?" Yuan stopped to look at her with a puzzled face.

"Why... you ask?" Min Li stood there with a somewhat dazed face, as she'd spoken without thinking just now.

However, this is also the first time someone has questioned her like this. If it were anybody else, they wouldn't even think about asking her why she wanted to follow them and would just accept it with a delighted smile on their face.

"I had also planned on heading to the Profound Pavilion to see if they have any techniques I can learn. Since you're going there now, I might as well tag along with you. Or do you not want me around you? Am I being a bother? If you're worried that I might attract unwanted attention, I can follow you from a distance," Min Li said to him a moment later.

"Well... It's not that you're being a bother... Whatever, you can do whatever you want," Yuan quickly gave up on giving an explanation and allowed her to follow him.

"Thank you, Disciple Yuan." Min Li showed him a beautifully bright smile.

Yuan didn't react much despite her charming appearance and nodded his head with a calm expression before turning around and walking again.

Min Li was speechless once again, and she stared at Yuan's back that was getting further away with a dazed look.

'He seems uninterested in me... This is a first.' Min Li thought to herself before she took her first step and began walking once Yuan was a dozen

meters away from her.

"Look over there! Isn't that Fairy Min from one of the Seven Legacy Families?!"

"You're right! And she looks absolutely stunning! I wonder where she's going?"

The disciples outside quickly took notice of Min Li's presence and conversations about her and her family immediately began between the disciples.

Hell, there were even a few disciples who began following her like the group of Inner Court disciples from before.

"Congratulations on passing the disciple examination and becoming a disciple, Fairy Min!"

"Fairy Min, do you have some time now? If you do, why don't we have a celebration?"

'She's really popular...' Yuan thought to himself as he could hear the disciples trying to talk to Min Li very clearly.

However, a few moments later, Min Li suddenly stopped walking and turned around to look at the group of disciples following behind her, and she spoke with a calm but cold expression on her face, "I am busy right now, can you all leave me alone?"

The disciples following her immediately stopped walking and looked at her with a dumbfounded expression before showing an embarrassed or awkward look on their faces.

"Thank you." Min Li did not even wait for their response and continued walking, subtly following Yuan from behind while keeping a safe distance so that people would only assume that they were coincidentally walking the same direction.

Meanwhile, Yuan followed the map inside his head that he'd memorized from the guidebook and slowly approached the Profound Pavilion.

Sometime later, Yuan arrived before a tall building that resembled the Myriad of Techniques in Spring City, but it was much more luxurious and grand compared to the ordinary-looking Myriad of Techniques.

After taking a moment to admire the building, Yuan walked inside.

Min Li followed him inside a moment later.

Once Yuan was inside the Profound Pavilion, he was immediately puzzled by the layout of the place. Unlike the Myriad of Pavilion, there were no techniques on display, and besides the reception and a staircase at the end of the building, there was nothing else there.

"You must be a new disciple."

One of the sect elders behind the desk suddenly called out to Yuan after seeing his face that looked like he was lost.

"Yes, I am." Yuan nodded before he approached the desk with a middle-aged man sitting behind it.

"What kind of techniques are you looking for, new disciple? Cultivation techniques? Martial techniques? Movement techniques?" The sect elder asked him a moment later.

"I'd like a technique that's specifically designed for daggers," Yuan said.

"So you're a dagger user, huh? What's your budget?" The sect elder then asked him.

"Budget? I have to pay for techniques here?" Yuan looked at the sect elder with a surprised look on his face as the guidebook never mentioned anything about needing to pay for the techniques!

"Of course you have to pay for the techniques. Did you think you'd get to learn techniques for free just because you are a disciple? This is why new

disciples are..." The sect elder shook his head.

"Well... I have around 200,000 gold coins left..." Yuan said a moment later.

"Gold coins?" The sect elder looked at Yuan with raised eyebrows before laughing out loud.

"Hahaha! You're a very amusing little guy, Outer Court disciple! When I say you have to pay for the techniques I didn't mean gold! This is the Profound Pavilion, not a store, and we accept no other currency besides contribution points!" The sect elder explained to him a moment later.

"If we charged the disciples real money, how will those from a common background learn any techniques? This is a sect, where a disciple's contribution and efforts take priority over everything else!"

"That makes sense..." Yuan nodded, and then he said, "If it's contribution points, I have exactly one thousand. What can I get with that much?"

"Excuse me? What did you just say? Did you just say that you have 1,000 contribution points?" The sect elder looked at Yuan with a face of disbelief.

"Yes," Yuan confirmed. "Or is that not enough for a technique?"

"Uhhh..." The sect elder was speechless.

One thousand contribution points was a massive amount for even an Inner Court disciple, much less an Outer Court disciple who'd just entered the sect! Hell, it would normally require ten years of collecting contribution points through sect missions for an ordinary disciple to save up that many contribution points! However, this Outer Court disciple who was clearly new to the sect had somehow managed to obtain 1,000 contribution points? That was outrageous!

Chapter 130 - Flying Daggers

"You have 1,000 contribution points? That's ridiculous!" The sect elder exclaimed in a loud voice, causing everybody there to look at them with a curious gaze

Meanwhile, Min Li watched Yuan from the corner of the building like a partner watching their children's first shopping experience.

'1,000 contribution points... even I only got 100 contribution points for joining the sect... why is there such a big disparity between the two of us?' Min Li pondered to herself as she continued trying to unveil Yuan's mysterious identity and seemingly unfathomable background.

"Since you claim to have 1,000 contribution points, let me see your identification token." The sect elder extended his arm with his hands open and his fingers gesturing to give it to him.

Yuan nodded and handed the sect elder his identification token without hesitation.

Once the identification token was in his hands, the sect elder used his spiritual energy to peek inside the token, and Yuan's identification appeared.

«Dragon Essence Temple Identification Gold Token»

«Disciple Name: Yuan»

«Disciple Status: Outer Disciple»

«Living Quarters: Outer Court, Building #70»

«Mission Completed: 0»

«Contribution Points: 1,000»

«Offenses: 0»

'Heavens! This Outer Court disciple has a gold identification token! And he really has 1,000 contribution points!' The sect elder cried inwardly after confirming that Yuan was not lying about his contribution points.

The sect elder swallowed nervously before turning to look at Yuan with a different kind of light in his eyes and with a respectful gaze.

There existed four grades of identification tokens in the Dragon Essence Temple. Bronze-grade, silver-grade, gold-grade, and finally, dragon-grade tokens.

Every grade of identification represented the importance of whoever held that token. For example, if a disciple has a bronze identification token, that person was an ordinary disciple without any impressive backgrounds.

Meanwhile, those with silver identification tokens are people with decent backings or have impressive talents.

As for those with a gold identification token, only those who come from prominent or powerful families such as the Seven Legacy Families are qualified to obtain one.

For the dragon identification token, only the Sect Masters or high-ranking elders are allowed to have it.

However, this ranking applied to not just disciples but to sect elders too, and in this case, the sect elder speaking with Yuan right now was only a bronze identification token holder! In other words, he was below Yuan in terms of status!

"T-Thank you, Disciple Yuan. I-I have confirmed your contribution points. Please give me a few moments to bring you the cultivation techniques

specialized for dagger users..." The sect elder spoke to Yuan in a respectful and humble tone, dumbfounding the people that had been watching them.

"Does that Outer Court disciple really have 1,000 contribution points? I cannot imagine what he must have gone through in order to collect so many contribution points!"

"You can obtain any cultivation technique you want from this place with that many contribution points! I envy him!"

The disciples began mumbling to each other about Yuan.

A few minutes later, the sect elder helping Yuan returned to the desk with over a dozen martial techniques that are best suited for daggers.

"Thank you for your patience, Disciple Yuan. I have brought pretty much every technique suitable for daggers from the back with me, and they are mostly Mortal-rank with a few exceptions at the Earth-rank. Please take your time looking through them," said the sect elder with a humble look on his face, dumbfounding Min Li and the other disciples, as it was an incredibly weird feeling to see a sect elder acting so humble before an Outer Court disciple who didn't have any reputation.

Yuan proceeded to look through the techniques one by one without reading the contents inside, as he was afraid of learning them by accident.

'Poison Stab... Night's Edge... Exploding Dagger... Zealous Piercer...'

Yuan spent the next few minutes reading the techniques' names and their description.

"Hmm? This is..."

Yuan looked at the last martial technique in the stack with an intrigued look on his face.

"Flying Daggers... Mortal-rank."

Even though the technique was only a Mortal-rank technique, the word 'flying' had instantly attracted his attention.

"It looks like you are interested in the Flying Dagger technique, Disciple Yuan. Although it's only a Mortal-rank technique, if mastered, you'll be able to defeat your opponents from a distance even with a weapon known for its short-range such as the dagger!" The sect elder said to him after seeing his intrigued face.

"How many contribution points for this technique? I want it," said Yuan, as the idea of defeating his enemies from afar sounded very cool to him.

"That technique would set you back 75 contribution points, Disciple Yuan," said the sect elder.

"Only 75 contribution points? That's very cheap! I'll take it!" Yuan said with a pleasantly surprised look on his face.

"Very cheap?" The sect elder's eyebrows twitched after hearing his words.

Although 75 contribution points may seem like nothing when he has 1,000 contribution points to spare, it would take a normal disciple almost an entire year to obtain!

"I understand. You want the Flying Dagger technique, right? I'll subtract it from your 1,000 contribution points now."

A few moments later, the sect elder handed the gold identification token back to Yuan.

"Good luck with the technique, Disciple Yuan."

"Thank you," Yuan nodded as he tossed the Flying Dagger technique into his Spatial Ring.

Once he'd gotten his technique, Yuan turned around and prepared to leave, and that was when he noticed Min Li standing in the background.

"Why are you standing there? Aren't you going to get a technique, too?" Yuan asked her.

"No, I am fine. I don't need any techniques," she calmly shook her head.

Yuan was speechless after hearing her words. If she didn't need any techniques then why did she follow him all the way over here, even saying that she planned on coming here?

"Anyway, what are you going to do now that you've gotten a technique? Are you going to the practice field to try out your new technique?" Min Li then asked, dumbfounding Yuan even more with her eccentric behavior.

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Chapter 131 - Practice Area

"Practice field, huh. I do want to try out the Flying Daggers as soon as possible," Yuan nodded after Min Li's suggestion.

He then closed his eyes to recall the map inside his head to locate the training field.

After standing there for a few moments and locating the exact place, Yuan left the Profound Pavilion.

Of course, Min Li also left the Profound Pavilion and followed Yuan shortly after like some kind of stalker.

Sometime later, they arrived at the practice fields, a vast and spacious area that spanned for miles and was separated into four different parts.

One part of the area had these large and long walls that appeared to be made out of steel placed all over the area whilst a few disciples could be seen punching these steel walls.

In the second area, there were over a hundred human-shaped puppets made out of wood, and these puppets apparently could move on their own and defend themselves against the disciples' attack. However, these puppets didn't appear to have the capability to attack the disciple.

Meanwhile, in the third area, there were also puppets, and unlike the second area, these puppets attacked the disciples— aggressively at that.

As for the fourth area, there were a dozen mid-sized arenas and there were currently a few disciples sparring with each other on them.

There was actually a fifth area— the area in the middle, but it was completely empty with the exception of some disciples sitting on the floor with their eyes closed, seemingly cultivating.

Yuan immediately assumed this place to be a resting area for the disciples, as no sane Cultivator would truly do their cultivation out in the open and surrounded by so many people and noises.

"What are those walls over there? And why are they punching it repeatedly?" Yuan mumbled in a curious voice after seeing their unusual activities.

"That's the Wall of Absorption; it's said to be indestructible against physical attacks and have regeneration properties. They are very popular for those who wish to test out the full extent of their strength." Min Li suddenly responded to him from behind, startling him a bit.

"What about those puppets? Are they also indestructible?" Yuan asked her afterward.

"No, they're not, but they're extremely hard to break if you're not a Spirit Warrior," she said.

"If I... If I accidentally break one, how much do I have to reimburse the sect?" Yuan asked in a slightly nervous tone.

Min Li looked at him with her beautiful eyebrows raised, and she said, "Even I cannot break one at my full strength yet you think you can break one at whilst being two levels under me?"

"Well... You can't always be too careful. After all, they look expensive..."

Min Li was speechless. Despite his seemingly profound background, Yuan did not act like someone that belongs to a powerful family.

There was a clear hint of naivety and innocence around him, but there was also something charming about him that kept her interest piqued.

"You won't have to pay for any damages done to the puppets so you don't have to worry about breaking them," Min Li said a moment later.

"I see. Thank you," Yuan said to her before he retrieved the Flying Daggers technique and began reading through it.

Min Li raised her eyebrows yet again after seeing this.

"What are you doing now?" She asked him.

"I'm learning the technique," Yuan responded in a calm voice.

"What?" Min Li's eyes widened, and she pointed at the area in the center of the practice area and said, "Why don't you do it over there? There's a formation that cancels out unwanted noise so you'll have absolute peace and silence while inside—"

However, before Min Li could even finish her sentence, Yuan closed the technique and tossed it back into his Spatial Ring with a calm expression on his face.

«You have learned Flying Daggers»

[Flying Daggers]

[Rank: Mortal]

[Mastery Level: 1]

[Description: Control your daggers with spiritual energy and send them flying through the battlefield, slaying your enemies from a distance! Qi consumption will vary depending on how many Daggers you control at once and its speed.]

Min Li would've never thought that Yuan could have learned the technique in such a short time so she assumed that he was only putting away the technique so he could listen to her advice and go to the resting area.

However, when Min Li noticed that Yuan was walking towards the second area where the defensive puppets were instead, she frowned with a puzzled look on her beautiful face.

'What the... Where is he going?' Min Li wondered to herself as she watched Yuan stand before a puppet.

A few moments later, she watched as Yuan retrieved a very beautiful black dagger that did not have any unique aura to it.

'What a beautiful weapon... but I don't sense anything special coming from it— is it just an ordinary weapon with good looks?' Min Li thought to herself.

'Hmm? Why is he bringing out a weapon now when he still hasn't learned the technique? What's he trying to do?'

Meanwhile, Yuan placed the Starry Abyss flat on his palms, and he activated Flying Daggers.

The Starry Abyss began trembling the next second, and after a few more seconds, it began levitating in the air with a subtle red glow around the dagger.

"WHAT?!"

When Min Li saw the dagger flying above Yuan, she uncontrollably shouted in a shocked voice, quickly attracting the attention of everyone there.

"Isn't that Fairy Min? What's she doing here? And did that loud voice come from her just now?"

"I think it was somebody else. After all, why would Fairy Min suddenly shout?"

"What do you think she's watching? Do you think she might be watching us train?"

"That might be the case! Let's try not to embarrass ourselves now!"

The disciples in the practice area began training with even more intensity because they wanted to impress Fairy Min, but alas, little did they know that she was not paying attention to them whatsoever, and her gaze was locked onto Yuan's figure.

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Chapter 132 - Destroying The Training Puppe

'Is that the technique he'd just obtained from the Profound Pavilion—Flying Daggers?! But that's impossible! He didn't have the time to learn it!' Min Li cried inwardly after witnessing Yuan levitate the Starry Abyss.

Then she recalled that brief moment that Yuan took to look through the technique, but that only lasted for a minute at most if not even shorter. How can someone learn an entire technique in less than a minute? Even if it's the lowest rank technique, such a feat shouldn't be possible!

"It must be a different technique..." Min Li forced herself to believe that Yuan was only using a similar technique.

However, when she saw Yuan controlling the dagger and making it fly around exactly like the technique Flying Daggers would do, her eyes widened with shock again.

'T-That's really the Flying Daggers technique! He'd really managed to learn a Mortal-rank technique in a minute! Just what is his background?! Even the top geniuses from the Seven Legacy Families pales in comparison to him!'

'Wait a second...' Min Li suddenly thought of a possibility.

'The Four Ancient Families... Could he be from one of the Four Ancient Families?!' Min Li pondered to herself with a serious frown on her face.

The Four Ancient Families are very similar to the Seven Legacy Families in the way that they are only a branch family that has a main family

somewhere in the upper heavens. However, other than that, the two powers were completely different.

While the Seven Legacy Families are known for their influence and large family size, in terms of power and influence, the Four Ancient Families vastly surpasses the Seven Legacy Families by a long shot!

Furthermore, very little is known about the Four Ancient Families, as they don't usually show up in public or participate in large gatherings. One can say they are a mysterious background with immense power that is at the peak of the Lower Heavens.

'If this Disciple Yuan is really from one of the Four Ancient Families, it would make sense as to why he's so talented but at the same time a nobody that no one recognizes," Min Li thought to herself as she watched Yuan improve with the Flying Daggers technique at a shocking speed.

Meanwhile, Yuan was having the time of his life controlling the Starry Abyss in the air, and once he'd familiarized himself with the technique, he began using it to attack the defensive puppets.

"Flying Dagger!" Yuan activated his spiritual energy and directed the Starry Abyss in the air to fly straight at the puppet, and the Starry Abyss trembled for a split second before shooting itself towards the puppet like a shooting star.

Whoosh!

The Starry Abyss arrived before the puppet before one could even finish blinking their eyes and struck the puppet in the center of its head before it could even react.

Boom!

The defensive puppet was sent flying backward, even hitting another puppet in the back before stopping.

"So powerful!" Yuan mumbled in a dumbfounded voice when he saw the destructive power from the technique. "And this is only a Mortal-rank technique? Or is the power mostly due to the Starry Abyss because it's a Soul Weapon?"

Meanwhile, Min Li's mouth was wide open from shock after she witnessed the powerful blow from the Flying Daggers techniques.

'What the heck?! The Flying Daggers is only a Mortal-rank technique and is known for being fast but weak! Yet he's displaying power with the technique that rivals even Earth-rank destructive techniques! Not to mention, he'd just learned the technique not long ago!' Min Li cried inwardly.

A few moments later, the puppet that had been struck by the Abyss Dagger slowly returned to standing in front of Yuan, but there was a small crack on its forehead.

'Even though I don't have to pay for it, I shouldn't destroy it...' Yuan thought to himself, and he proceeded to continue his training with the Flying Daggers technique, and every time he went to strike the defensive puppet, he made sure to hit the puppet in a new area and avoided the cracked areas.

Once the puppet was full of cracks, Yuan went to another puppet and continued his training.

About half an hour later, another notification appeared.

«Your comprehension for Flying Daggers has reached a new level!»

«Flying Daggers Mastery Level (1) → (2)»

[Flying Daggers]

[Rank: Mortal]

[Mastery Level: 2]

"Let's see just how much of a difference a single mastery level makes!" Yuan mumbled to himself in anticipation before using the Flying Daggers on the Starry Abyss and attacking a brand new defensive puppet at full power and speed.

Whoosh!

The Starry Abyss floating in the air suddenly flickered and disappeared, and in the speed it takes for one to blink, the Starry Abyss had already reached the puppet in the chest.

BOOM!

To Yuan's surprise, the Starry Abyss not only sent the puppet flying but it'd also created a hole the size of one's fist in the middle of the puppet's chest.

Clang!

Once the puppet bumped into another puppet many meters away, the puppet struck by the Starry Abyss broke into two pieces, dumbfounding Yuan and every disciple in the practice area that had been startled by the loud noise created by the impact.

"H-H-He broke the Training Puppet! I have never seen anyone achieve that before!"

"Just who is that disciple?! I don't recognize his face!"

The disciples there mumbled to each other after witnessing a Training Puppet being destroyed in such a vicious manner for the first time.

"He... He really destroyed a Training Puppet..." Min Li mumbled to herself in a low voice and stood there with a dazed face.

A few moments later, Min Li suddenly began making her way towards the second area with a sword in her hands and a resolute look on her beautiful face.

"Look at that! Fairy Min is also going to challenge the Training Puppet! She definitely wants to try it herself after seeing what that disciple achieved!"
The disciples noticed her actions and watched in anticipation.

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Chapter 133 - Challenging Yuan

'If he can destroy a Training Puppet whilst being two whole levels below me in cultivation, not to mention with a Mortal-rank technique, there's no reason why I, Min Li, cannot destroy one too!' Min Li thought to herself with a resolute look on her face, feeling as though she'd been challenged by Yuan after seeing his dazzling display.

Every single disciple in the practice area including Yuan stopped whatever they were doing to watch Min Li, who stood before a Training Puppet with an ordinary sword in her hands and a serious but still beautiful look on her face.

'Since he'd used an ordinary weapon and a Mortal-rank technique, I shall do the same!' Min Li thought to herself as she prepared her mind and sword.

After taking a deep breath, Min Li moved.

She took a step forward with the sword in her hand raised and trembling.

"Haa!"

Min Li shouted out loud as she swung the sword in her hands.

Boom!

The Training Puppet flew many meters away from the impact.

"Wow! As expected of Fairy Min! To think she could display such strength with a Mortal-rank technique!"

"That's true, but... compared to that other disciple... it felt a little bit lacking... I think..." One of the disciples there suddenly mumbled.

"You idiot! Don't say that out loud! What if Fairy Min hears you?!"
Another whispered.

"..."

Min Li's eyebrows twitched a little bit when she heard those disciples talk, but she pretended as though she didn't hear it and focused on the Training Puppet.

A moment later, the Training Puppet returned, and as she'd expected, there wasn't any damage on the puppet despite such a powerful blow.

Min Li stared at the Training Puppet with a frown on her face, but she wasn't discouraged, as the previous attack was only a warmup.

After taking another breath, Min Li displayed her second strike, and the sword in her hand emitted an even more powerful aura than previously.

Boom!

The Training Puppet was sent flying once again by the strike.

"Wow! That strike was at least twice as powerful as the last one! And it surpassed even the other disciple's attacks at first!"

"As expected of Fairy Min! I knew her first strike was only a warmup!"

However, despite the disciples' praises, Min Li did not feel happy even in the slightest, as she knew very well that it wasn't enough to destroy the Training Puppet.

The Training Puppet returned to her side a moment later, and there was a slight crack on its body, but it was nothing significant and could only be considered as superficial damage.

'How is this possible?' Min Li pondered to herself. 'Although I am only using an ordinary weapon, my mastery with this Mortal-rank technique has long reached its peak after training with it for over ten years, yet it cannot compare to his Flying Daggers technique that he'd just learned not long ago! This doesn't make any sense! Unless...'

Min Li turned to look at the beautiful weapon in Yuan's grasp.

'Unless that's not an ordinary weapon at all! I'd been fooled by its lack of aura! That weapon is definitely a powerful treasure! There's no way someone from the Ancient Family will carry around an ordinary weapon! Since that's the case, I will also use my personal weapon!'

After convincing herself that Yuan's Starry Abyss was actually a treasure and not an ordinary weapon at all, Min Li stowed away her ordinary sword and retrieved another sword—a beautiful blue sword that emitted a sharp and profound aura that sent chills down the disciples' back when they saw it.

"There it is! Fairy Min's Heaven-grade treasure, the Eternal Fairy Needle!"

"Wow, the blade of that sword is incredibly thin! I have never seen anything like that before! But won't it affect its durability?"

"Are you stupid? That's a Heaven-grade treasure! You cannot judge treasures by their appearance! Even though it has an incredibly thin blade, it's actually more durable than even broadswords— at least that's what I heard."

Whilst the disciples mumbled to each other, Min Li prepared herself for the third strike.

Sometime later, Min Li stepped forward while shouting in a loud voice.

"Haaaa!"

The eternal Fairy Needle in her grasp flew forward, striking the Training Puppet directly on the chest.

BOOM!

The Training Puppet was sent flying like it'd been launched by a rocket launcher and landed in the third practice area many meters in the distance.

"Heavens... what a powerful strike! I don't think I have seen even Earth-grade techniques display such power!"

"Do you think Fairy Min managed to destroy the Training Puppet with that strike just now?"

"Of course! There's simply no way the Training Puppet could've survived that!"

However, to everybody's surprise, the Training Puppet returned a few moments later with only a large crack in its chest.

"What the heck? Are the Training Puppets really that durable? To the point where it can withstand even a Heaven-grade treasure?!"

"If that's the case, then how powerful is that disciple who'd destroyed it completely?!"

The disciples were shocked beyond belief when they realized just how difficult it was to destroy a Training Puppet, and they all turned to look at Yuan who had been standing there with an innocent face with shocked gazes.

Meanwhile, Min Li stared at the Training Puppet with a slightly angry look on her face, feeling irritated for the first time in many years. As a genius who is often praised by her surroundings and with very few rivals in her life, she cannot help but feel angry when she suddenly meets another individual who she cannot even begin to compare to, not to mention she was being watched by hundreds of other disciples.

'I know I'd dug this hole myself when I decided to challenge him, but I have vastly underestimated him! If I don't destroy the Training Puppet, my face will be in jeopardy!' Min Li thought to herself.

'Since it has come to this, I must go all out even if I am cheating a little!'

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Chapter 134 - Admitting Defeat

'If I don't destroy a Training Puppet today, it won't just affect my reputation but also my family! I cannot let that happen no matter what! Not even if I have to sacrifice all of my faces!' Min Li thought to herself.

A moment later, she took a deep breath before taking a unique stance.

When the other disciples saw this and recognized her stance, they immediately shouted with excitement.

"That's the Min Family's most powerful technique— a Divine-rank technique!"

"What?! She's going from a Mortal-rank technique to a Divine-rank technique?! Does she want to destroy that Training Puppet so badly?"

"Well, think about it as though you are in her shoes. She was the one who decided to challenge that disciple who'd manage to destroy the Training Puppet. If she loses, it'll affect her reputation alongside her family's reputation, and you know how much the Seven Legacy Families value their reputation!"

"But that disciple used a Mortal-rank technique... and it was even the Flying Daggers technique that is known for being weak! If she uses a Divine-rank technique, wouldn't that be cheating and count as her loss regardless?"

"Well, yeah, but at least she will save some face for destroying the Training Puppet."

While the disciples mumbled to each other, Min Li focused on her next and final attack, even picking a new Training Puppet that did not have any cracks to make it a little bit fairer.

'This will definitely make me lose face, but at least I will destroy the Training Puppet!'

With that in mind, Min Li took a step forward, causing the ground to tremble a little, and she swung the sword in her hands that radiated with a profound aura.

"HAAAAAAAAAH!"

Min Li shouted at the top of her lungs, attempting to force every ounce of strength in her body out with her voice.

BOOOOM!

An explosion occurred upon impact, and the Training Puppet was sent flying like a shooting star, crashing into many other Training Puppets.

"Heavens..."

The other disciples' jaw dropped to the ground when they witnessed the destructive power of the Divine-rank technique. There was simply no way the Training Puppet would be able to move again after being hit by such a powerful strike!

"Haaa... haaa... haaaa... Did I... destroy it...?"

Min Li knelt on the ground with an exhausted expression on her face while panting heavily.

The Divine-rank technique had exhausted pretty much all of her spiritual energy, making something as easy as standing a difficult task for her.

The other disciples also watched with nervous expressions, their gazes all staring at the mountain of Training Puppets that had piled up after the Min Li's attack.

A few moments later, the Training Puppets began moving once again and slowly returned to their original spots.

However, the disciples and Min Li didn't care about the other Training Puppets— only the one that she'd struck.

Two minutes later, they could finally see the Training Puppet that Min Li attacked.

"I-Impossible..." Min Li mumbled with clear disbelief on her face as the Training Puppet that she'd struck slowly approached her with a long and deep cut on its chest, feeling quite intimidating for some reason.

A few moments later, the Training Puppet stood before Min Li once again, clearly still functional and not completely destroyed despite the damage it'd sustained that would instantly kill any Cultivator.

"H-How is that possible?"

The other disciples there were also in disbelief, and they turned to look at Yuan with a fearful expression on their faces.

If Yuan could destroy the Training Puppet completely with a Mortal-rank technique whilst Min Li could not achieve the same results with a Divine-rank technique and a Heaven-grade treasure, just how much more powerful is he?

'Damn it! Just who is this Disciple Yuan?!' Min Li cried inwardly and stared at Yuan with a frustrated look on her face.

Meanwhile, Yuan, who was completely oblivious that Min Li had challenged him, said to her, "Wow, that was such a powerful technique! I am impressed!"

Cough

Min Li nearly coughed up a mouthful of blood after hearing Yuan's words, as she misunderstood it for mockery.

'T-This is the first time I've been humiliated in such a manner! He'd even mocked me for daring to challenge him!'

However, as frustrated as she was, Min Li wasn't angry at Yuan, mostly because she was the one who'd challenged him in the first place, even blaming herself for not being strong enough.

"You... How old are you?" Min Li asked Yuan sometime later.

"Me? 18 years old," Yuan calmly responded.

"..."

Min Li stared at him with a gawking expression.

'He's the same age as me?! Yet there's such a vast disparity between us?! He's definitely from one of the Four Ancient Families! I am almost certain now!' Min Li cried inwardly.

"Anyway, I am going to return home for now..." Yuan turned around and walked away.

However, Min Li shouted at him, "Wait for a second!"

"Yes?" Yuan looked at her with a calm expression.

"I... I won't lose to you next time! Regardless of your background, I am going to win next time!" Min Li declared with a determined look on her face.

"Uhh... Okay?" Yuan raised his eyebrows in a puzzled manner, as he had no idea what she was talking about, but he figured that it would be for the best to just nod his head and accept it.

"..."

Min Li was speechless. Does she really look that insignificant in his eyes? Are the Four Ancient Families really that much more powerful than the Seven Legacy Families?

'Hmph! Just you wait! Although I may be nothing more than an ant in your eyes right now, I swear that I will catch up to you and make you recognize

me as your equal!' Min Li swore to herself as she watched Yuan disappear from the practice area.

Meanwhile, Yuan returned to his home and acted as though nothing special had happened, completely unaware that he'd made Min Li think of him as a rival!

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Chapter 135 - Unbelievable Rumor

"Just who was that Outer Court disciple? I have never seen him before, nor do I recognize his face! Does anyone here know him?" One of the disciples there suddenly asked out loud.

"No, I have also never seen him around here before, and I come to this place nearly every day!"

"Me neither! I have trained here every day for the past 2 years without missing a single day and I also don't recognize him!"

Since nobody there recognized Yuan's identity, they all turned to look at Fairy Min with a questioning gaze.

After a moment of silence, one of them decided to ask her, "Fairy Min, do you perhaps know who that Outer Court disciple was?"

"I don't know him!" Min Li responded in an irritated voice before standing up and patting her clothes and knees.

Once she'd fixed her appearance, Min Li walked away while resisting the urge to cry, as she'd unintentionally suffered a humiliating defeat by Yuan before so many disciples, which will surely affect her reputation and possibly her family's face.

Sometime later, once Min Li left the scene, the disciples at the practice area looked at each other and said, "Did you see how dejected Fairy Min looked just now? I think it would be better if we don't talk about this..."

"Yeah, I think so too. After all, talking bad about Fairy Min is akin to slapping the Min Family in the face, and I don't want to risk offending one of the Seven Legacy Families."

"Me too! I didn't see anything here today!"

"Good! Then let's act as though nothing happened here today!"

However, even if the majority of the disciples there agreed to keep what happened today a secret, there were bound to be a few of them who couldn't keep their mouths shut and spoke about the event at the practice area to others, which quickly spread throughout the sect as a rumor.

Luckily for Fairy Min, since only a few people spoke about it at first, the other disciples doubted this rumor when they heard it, as it was simply too unbelievable.

"What? Fairy Min lost to some unknown Outer Court disciple in a challenge? That's outrageous!"

"Some unknown Outer Court disciple managed to destroy a Training Puppet with an ordinary dagger and a Mortal-rank technique—the Flying Daggers technique, no less? How is that possible? You must have been dreaming!"

"There's no way Fairy Min would lose to some nobody! Quit your bullshit!"

"I am telling you the truth! If you go to the practice area now, you would see many cracked Training Puppets! These damages had been done by that Outer Court disciple!" The disciple that spread the rumors said, feeling slightly annoyed that nobody believed him.

"Do you think I am stupid? Of course, there would be cracked Training Puppets in the practice area! Do you know how many disciples practice there every day? I'd personally cracked one myself after hitting it over 1,000 times in a single day!"

"That's not what I mean!"

"Hmph! I don't know who you are but if you continue to gossip about Fairy Min in a negative light, I will personally give your skull some cracks! Get lost!"

"..."

That disciple was speechless. After pondering for a minute, he realized that it made sense why nobody would believe him, as the event was simply too unbelievable! If he didn't witness it himself, he would've definitely reacted the same as these disciples.

Meanwhile, after returning to her own room, Min Li collapsed on the bed with her head buried deep inside her pillow and began crying her eyes out, releasing all of her frustration alone after today's defeat.

"I swear I won't lose to you next time, Disciple Yuan!" Min Li cried out loud sometime later.

As for Yuan, he was casually laying on the comfortable bed inside his room while staring at the floating Starry Abyss in the air. Even though he'd already reached mastery level 2 for this technique, he just cannot seem to get enough of it, as it'd reminded him of the flying sword.

"Hopefully I'll be able to control a flying sword soon," he mumbled in a low voice.

After spending some time reading the guidebook some more to decide where he wanted to go for tomorrow, Yuan logged off the game to cultivate in the real world until Yu Rou returned from school to feed him dinner.

'Even though I haven't slept in an entire week, I don't feel tired, even filled to the brim with energy. I wonder if this is actually healthy for me...' Yuan wondered to himself as he calmed his mind to prepare for another night of cultivation.

However, unlike the past few days, Yuan did not cultivate throughout the whole night and decided to cultivate only for a few hours before going to sleep.

The next morning, Yu Rou said to him, "Brother, Doctor Wang will be coming later this morning. Do you think you can wait for him to finish

before you play the game? I have school so I won't be able to attend, but Meixiu will be here if you need anything."

"Okay," Yuan said.

Once Yu Rou left for school, Yuan began cultivating until someone knocked on his room.

"Young Master, Doctor Wang is here to see you," Meixiu knocked on his door and said.

"Let him in," Yuan responded.

Doctor Wang entered the room with Meixiu a moment later.

"How have you been feeling lately, Young Master? Does your body hurt anywhere? Do you feel any different than usual?" Doctor Wang asked him.

"No, I feel as great as usual," Yuan quickly responded.

'As great as usual...?' Doctor Wang raised his eyebrows in a surprised manner. Normally, one wouldn't claim to feel 'great' if they were in Yuan's condition.

"T-That's great to hear. Anyway, I have brought some equipment with me to scan your body today, but since this is portable equipment, it is also weaker than the ones in the hospital, so I will need to remove your clothes." Doctor Wang said before turning to look at Meixiu and said, "Do you mind helping the Young Master strip while I prepare the equipment? Thank you."

"Uhhhh..." A speechless and perplexed look appeared on Meixiu's face, but she nodded regardless, and then she approached Yuan on the bed a moment later.

Chapter 136 - A Bug In The System

"Excuse me, Young Master. I'll be removing your clothes now," Meixiu said to him once she was beside the bed.

"Go ahead," Yuan said.

Meixiu swallowed nervously and reached for Yuan's pajamas with trembling hands.

Although Yu Rou had specifically told her to not touch Yuan unless absolutely necessary, she also told her to assist Doctor Wang if he requested help, which conflicted with each other and placed Meixiu in a difficult spot.

A few moments later, Meixiu stripped Yuan until he was stark naked.

"Uhh..."

When Doctor Wang saw this, he spoke in an awkward voice, "You didn't need to remove his underwear..."

"Ah! I am so sorry, Young Master! I wasn't thinking properly just now!" Meixiu exclaimed in a startled voice after realizing her mistake, and she quickly went to put Yuan's underwear back on his body, but alas, she'd unintentionally touched something soft while fixing his underwear due to her panicked and hasty movements.

'T-The Young Lady is going to kill me if she finds out that I'd soiled the Young Master's body with my hands...!' Meixiu cried inwardly after she realized what she'd done.

"Haha..." Yuan suddenly laughed, and he said, "You've always been clumsy, Meixiu. Don't worry about it too much."

"B-But the Young Lady..."

"I won't say anything if you won't," Yuan said with a smile on his face.

"..." Meixiu was speechless. Is she really going to keep this a secret from Yu Rou?

"I-I understand, Young Master... Thank you... and sorry..." Meixiu bowed to him despite the fact that Yuan wouldn't be able to see it.

Doctor Wang shook his head when he saw this, but this wasn't any of his business, so he acted as though it had never happened.

Sometime later, Doctor Wang approached the bed with the equipment by his side.

However, Doctor Wang's eyes widened with shock when he saw Yuan's body.

"Y-Y-Young Master! What happened to your body?!" Doctor Wang exclaimed in a shocked voice.

"Huh? Did something happen to my body?" Yuan's eyebrows quickly furrowed into a worried face.

"N-No... It's just that... compared to last week, your body is much bulkier and clearly has more muscles in general, almost like you've been working out." Doctor Wang spoke in a dumbfounded voice, as this is a situation that he has never encountered before.

After all, how does a cripple who cannot move anything below his neck suddenly obtain muscles when all he does is lay around in the bed all day?

Meixiu couldn't help but glance at Yuan's body out of curiosity, and sure enough, there were some defined areas on his body— something she didn't notice before because she was too nervous.

"I... have no idea..." Yuan said despite having a clue as to what might have caused this, and he continued, "Maybe it's because I have been eating three

bowls of soup instead of just one every meal?"

"Uhhh..." Doctor Wang was speechless. If drinking three bowls of soup per meal would give one muscle without doing anything, everybody in the world would drink soup every day for all three meals! If anything, Yuan should be getting fatter, yet one could easily tell at a glance that the muscles on Yuan's body were real muscles and not fat!

"Excuse me, Young Master, I am going to take a quick look at your body..." Doctor Wang began testing the toughness of Yuan's muscles.

'Heavens! His muscles are even stronger than mine! Although I may be old, I shouldn't lose to someone like the Young Master who hasn't lifted a finger for many years!' Doctor Wang cried inwardly after his quick assessment.

'This... is this a good thing?' Doctor Wang pondered with a serious look on his face as he was unsure of how to diagnose Yuan's situation.

While it would normally be a good thing for someone to gain muscles, it might be troublesome for someone like Yuan who cannot use his body. What if his muscles continue to grow to the point where it might harm Yuan's body instead?

Sometime later, Doctor Wang decided to scan Yuan's body before he decided on anything.

Doctor Wang then placed four pieces of equipment that resembled large bracelets on Yuan's body, one on each limb.

Afterward, Doctor Wang placed a dozen wired sensors all over Yuan's body and connected it to the monitor beside the bed.

"I am going to scan your body now, Young Master." Doctor Wang said as he pressed a button on the monitor.

A few moments later, the equipment began glowing a neon green color, and the wired sensors also began trembling slightly while glowing as well.

After waiting for a few minutes, Doctor Wang could see an x-ray of Yuan's body on the monitor.

"W-What is this?" Doctor Wang mumbled in a dazed voice when he saw the results.

Doctor Wang then rubbed his eyes for a few seconds before looking at the monitor again, and sure enough, he was not dreaming and he could see Yuan's bones glowing a subtle but golden color.

'Is this a glitch in the system?' Doctor Wang immediately came to this conclusion as it was the only logical one he could think of. 'Well, this equipment is not as powerful or accurate as the ones in the hospital, so something like this can happen from time to time...'

'But I'll do it again just in case.'

Doctor Wang proceeded to restart the monitor before scanning Yuan's body again.

A few minutes later, the same results came back but with even more clarity.

'What the heck? Why does it look like there are golden symbols etched onto the Young Master's bones?' Doctor Wang was truly baffled speechless this time, as he could not find a logical explanation for this phenomenon other than it being a weird glitch in the software. After all, there was simply no way there could be golden symbols engraved onto Yuan's bones, as that would require surgery, something Yuan clearly hasn't had since ever.

"Is everything okay?" Yuan asked him sometime later.

"Y-Yes... your bones seem to be okay," Doctor Wang hastily said, treating the golden symbols as a bug in the system.

Chapter 137 - Perfectly Healthy

After checking Yuan's x-ray, Doctor Wang proceeded to test Yuan's blood and a few other things.

Once the results came back and there was nothing abnormal, Doctor Wang said, "Okay, I am done with your checkup, Young Master. Your body is as healthy as usual, and there's nothing wrong with your blood. In fact, I would even say that you're getting healthier every time I see you."

"Do you have any questions for me before I leave, Young Master?"

"Yes... Doctor Wang... Am I... Is my condition really caused by some unknown and undetectable illness?" Yuan suddenly asked.

After all, if the Translucent Dew of Flawlessness and Feng Yixiao's phoenix blood had affected him in real life, why didn't the phoenix blood heal his condition when it supposedly cured all of illness and injuries? Why is he still crippled?

"..."

Doctor Wang shook his head in a solemn manner. After a moment of silence, he spoke, "I've already told you this many times already, Young Master, but we cannot find anything wrong with your body. Your blood, your bones, your muscles— anything that could be tested in your body we have already tested and multiple times too. However, the results are always the same— you are completely healthy."

"With that being said, there's no way someone healthy would suddenly lose their ability to move their body and see, so we could only conclude that it is a new illness that can avoid our current technology. I'm really sorry that I cannot be of more help to you, Young Master. I am also really ashamed to

even call myself a doctor whenever I am before you..." Doctor Wang sighed.

"There's no need for you to feel guilty, Doctor Wang. I understand that there are some things in this world that cannot be fixed no matter what, and I am simply one of those things," Yuan said to him with a smile on his face.

"Young Master... You are truly too kind..." Doctor Wang said, feeling an urge to cry.

'Why did the heavens punish the Young Master in such a way? What did he do to deserve this kind of life? This is too cruel even if the heavens are jealous of the Young Master's talents.' Doctor Wang sighed inwardly.

Sometime later, Meixiu escorted Doctor Wang outside before returning to his room.

"Do you need anything from me, Young Master?" Meixiu asked him afterward.

"Uhh... can you help me put my clothes back on?" Yuan said.

"Oh! Right! I nearly forgot about that!" Meixiu quickly went to put on his clothes as she didn't want to be responsible if Yuan catches a cold because of it.

"I am going in the game now," Yuan said to her afterward.

"I understand, Young Master. I'll head to school to serve the Young Lady now," Meixiu said.

"Have fun..." Yuan said.

'Fun...?' Meixiu thought to herself. While she found helping Yu Rou fun, there was nothing fun about going to school, where she must act like a student and a servant at the same time.

Although Meixiu is a maid, she is also a student at the same time, and because of Yu Rou, she got to attend the same prestigious school as Yu Rou.

And because only rich and famous students go to that school, it was common seeing these students bringing their servants to school with them.

Sometime later, Meixiu left the room and closed the lights whilst Yuan returned to Cultivation Online.

After returning to his room in the disciple, Yuan sat on the bed and spoke out loud, "Xiao Hua, Feng Feng, I have a question. Can you come out for a moment?"

A second later, Xiao Hua came out of his necklace whilst Feng Yixiao emerged from his chest.

"What's the matter, Young Master?" Feng Yixiao asked him.

"Well... it's like this..."

Yuan proceeded to tell them about his condition in the real world without saying it's him.

"Wow, that sounds horrible..." Feng Yixiao shook her head afterward, and she continued, "If I had to live like that, I'd probably ask to be killed."

"..."

Yuan was speechless. But it was not as though he didn't understand Feng Yixiao's thoughts.

"Feng Feng, you said that your phoenix blood could cure all illness, right? What if a person in that condition consumes your blood but doesn't heal? Then what would that mean?" Yuan then asked her.

"Indeed, my phoenix blood can cure all illnesses. However, there is a limit to such abilities, as it will only cure mortal illnesses," she said.

"Mortal illness? What does that even mean?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

Xiao Hua then spoke, "Just like poison and medicine, there are many levels of illnesses. In other words, there are illnesses only mortals can have whilst

Cultivators are immune to them. However, that goes both ways as there are illnesses that can only affect Cultivators but not mortals, as we have different bodies and immune systems."

"Heavens... I didn't know there exists such a thing..." Yuan mumbled.

"Anyway, my blood can heal all mortal illnesses and most illnesses that affect only Cultivators. If this is a Cultivator we're talking about then that is most likely the case. If the crippled person is a mortal... then that person must have contracted something extremely rare and powerful that would even affect Cultivators."

"Is this person someone you know, Young Master? If that's the case, it'd be better if you find a real expert. After all, we're not doctors... at least I don't think so..." Feng Yixiao turned to look at Xiao Hua who shook her head.

"Xiao Hua only knows the basics," she said.

"A real expert, huh? Where can I find one?" Yuan then asked.

"I know of a few renowned doctors in the Lower Heavens but they are always traveling so I don't always know where they are. However, if I sense their aura, I'll immediately let you know, Young Master." Feng Yixiao said.

"Thanks a bunch, Feng Feng. I'll be counting on you." Yuan nodded.

Chapter 138 - Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower

After talking to Feng Yixiao and Xiao Hua for a few more minutes, they returned to their own 'home' while Yuan prepared to leave the house once again to explore the sect.

However, before Yuan could even take a dozen steps out of his house, a familiar voice resounded, "Where are you going?"

Yuan turned around to see Min Li standing by the door with slightly dark eyes, almost like she didn't get enough sleep last night or something.

"I am going to the 'Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower'," Yuan responded with a super long name.

"Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower?!" Min Li looked at him with widened eyes.

The Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower is a unique place in the sect where disciples go to test their skills and challenge their limits by fighting powerful beasts, and the faster one defeats the beasts the higher score they will obtain. The place is so popular and important to the sect and disciples that there is even a ranking just for it, allowing the disciples to compete with each other for the top ranks.

However, because of its difficulties, only those who have been in the sect for over a year would dare to challenge it unless they were talented geniuses from powerful families such as Min Li.

But even someone like Min Li wouldn't challenge the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower so quickly and without any preparations.

'This guy... It's only his second day as a disciple and he's already challenging that place?! Just how much is he trying to show off his talents?!' Min Li cried inwardly.

When she saw Yuan walking away a moment later, she quickly said, "W-Wait a moment! I am coming too!"

Yuan raised his eyebrows. Why is she following him again? But since he didn't have an issue with it nor a reason to shoo her away, he didn't say anything in the end.

Sometime later, they arrived before an incredibly tall building that almost pierced the clouds; it was so tall that Yuan was able to see it from his building, hence why he'd managed to get to this place without any problems. Furthermore, there were two more of these towers further in the distance, presumably within the Inner Court and the Center of the sect.

There were at least 100 floors in this massive tower, and there was also an incredibly large golden board located next to the entrance with many disciples around it.

"Look! Ming Yong defeated the guardian on the 51st floor and entered the 52nd floor! He has managed to enter the top 200!"

The disciples there shouted with excitement when the name 'Ming Yong' appeared on the bottom of the list on the golden board that had a total of 200 names on it.

Yuan looked up and sure enough, there was a golden light emitting from the windows on the 51st floor.

"If you want to become an Inner Court disciple, you must defeat at least 30 floors. 75 floors if you want to be a Core disciple," Min Li said to him from behind.

"How does it work?" Yuan asked her without looking back.

"Every floor will have a magical beast that you must defeat in order to advance— some will have more than one. If you defeat the magical beast, you'll get to ascend to the next level, and you'll repeat this until you can no longer continue. Also, you are only allowed 15 minutes of rest for each floor." Min Li explained to him.

After a moment of silence, she asked him, "If you don't mind me asking, why are you challenging the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower now? You still have plenty of time until the next Inner Court disciple examination. Don't you want to improve your strength as much as possible before you challenge it?"

"I can challenge this place as many times as I want, right? Then why does it matter if I challenge it now or later? I also read from the guidebook that there will be a special reward for you if you manage to beat all 100 floors," Yuan said.

"100 floors?" Min Li looked at him from behind with a dumbfounded look on her face.

"There have been less than 10 disciples since the sect's founding that had managed to complete all 100 floors, and it has been over 1,000 years since the last disciple achieved such a feat. Do you really think you can complete 100 floors?" Min Li asked him.

And she continued, "Furthermore, the magical beasts in the tower are all illusions that adjust to your cultivation level so you can only rely on your own skills and talent to defeat them. Raw strength won't work."

"Oh? So I can train here regardless of my cultivation level? That's good to hear," said Yuan who wanted to hone his dagger and sword skills some more but is having a hard time finding opponents at his level.

"Can I go inside even though there's already someone inside? Or do I have to wait?" Yuan then asked.

"Only one person can challenge the tower at a time. You can register over there." Min Li pointed at the small pavilion a dozen meters away from them.

"Okay, then I'll..."

"Wait a second!" Min Li suddenly stopped him.

"What is it this time?" Yuan looked at her with raised eyebrows.

"I am going to go first this time!" Min Li said with a resolute look on her face.

"Uh... sure?" Yuan nodded. Since Min Li looked desperate to challenge the tower, Yuan didn't argue with her and allowed her to go first.

Min Li then approached the pavilion.

"Look over there! That's Min Li! It looks like she's going to challenge the tower too!"

"How daring! This is only her second day at the sect and she's already challenging the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower! As expected of a genius from one of the Seven Legacy Families!"

When the disciples there noticed her presence, they were immediately hyped, and they could not wait to see her performance.

Chapter 139 - Taking Longer Than Expected

"D-Disciple Min! Are you going to challenge the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower today?" The sect elder sitting in the small pavilion showed a surprised face and asked her in a slightly excited voice.

"Yes, I am." Min Li nodded and handed her disciple identification token to him.

"Very well! I have recorded your name, Disciple Min! Good luck!" The sect elder said to her.

After Min Li left the pavilion, Yuan approached the place and said to the sect elder, "I'd like to challenge the tower too."

"Let me see your identification token," the sect elder spoke in an uninterested tone, his attitude towards Yuan being completely different from Min Li which was expected.

"Here you go," Yuan handed his bronze identification token to the sect elder.

"You have been a disciple at the sect for only two days? And you want to challenge the tower? You must be full of yourself..." The sect elder shook his head at Yuan.

"Eh? But Disciple Min is the same as me..." Yuan said with a dumbfounded look.

"The same as you?! Outrageous! How dare you compare yourself to a genius from one of the Seven Legacy Families?! Who do you think you

are?!"

Yuan was speechless. Why is he being scolded? Did he say something wrong?

The sect elder then quickly recorded his name down before tossing the identification token back at him in a disrespectful manner.

"..."

Yuan stared at the sect elder with a frown on his face after catching the identification token.

"What are you looking at? You got something to say?" The sect elder frowned back.

"No..." Yuan decided that he didn't want to waste his energy on this sect elder and turned around and walked away, not to mention that he'd already argued with another sect elder not long ago.

A few minutes after returning to the tower, Yuan noticed a red light coming from the 52nd floor.

"Aiya! Ming Yong failed!"

"52 floors is still an incredible achievement since he'd managed to reach the top 200 in the Tower Ranking. Give him a few more years and he'll definitely reach 75 floors and become a Core disciple!"

A few more minutes later, the entrance to the tower opened, and a handsome young man walked out with a messy and bloodied appearance, looking like he'd been beaten and robbed by a group of bandits.

Seeing this, Min Li turned to look at Yuan and said to him before approaching the tower, "I won't lose to you this time, Disciple Yuan!"

Min Li then retrieved her Heaven-grade sword and entered the tower.

"Look! Fairy Min's going to challenge the tower next!"

The disciples there watched her enter the tower with admiration in their gazes, and even Ming Yong bowed to her despite being injured himself, "Good luck, Fairy Min."

"What floor do you think Fairy Min will reach?"

"Definitely over 60 floors!"

"I am willing to bet that she'll achieve over 75 floors!"

Meanwhile, Yuan stared at the Heaven-grade sword in Min Li's grasp.

"Xiao Hua, didn't you tell me before that one must have a sufficient cultivation level before they can wield a powerful treasure or their body will explode? How come she can wield a Heaven-grade treasure while being a Spirit Apprentice?" Yuan asked Xiao Hua in a low voice.

"In most cases, Cultivators are only allowed to wield treasures at their level. However, like most situations in the world, there are special cases where people can wield treasures much stronger than themselves. For example, that girl might have a powerful bloodline that allows her to achieve such a feat, or it could be explained by a mythical cultivation technique their family owns, as these kinds of techniques are quite common in the upper heavens, especially for the powerful families," Xiao Hua explained to him.

"Young Master, it could also be the weapon itself that's allowing that young lady to wield it despite her lacking cultivation base. After witnessing her strength yesterday, I can confidently say that was not the Heaven-grade's full potential. I have seen many spiritual treasures in my life, and there exist unique spiritual treasures that have such an ability." Feng Yixiao also gave her two cents.

And she continued, "However, regardless of how she's able to wield it, that young lady will not be able to display that spiritual treasure's full strength until she increases her own cultivation base."

"I see... thank you for the explanation." Yuan nodded.

Once Min Li entered the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower, the door closed behind her, and the first floor lightened with a greyish light.

A mere minute later, the greyish light on the first floor turned golden, signaling that Min Li had passed the first floor.

"Wow! As expected of Fairy Min! She's already cleared the first floor!"

"How incredibly fast! Most disciples take nearly 5 minutes on average to finish the first floor!"

Another minute later, a golden light appeared on the second floor and Min Li ascended to the third floor.

After spending ten minutes inside the tower, Min Li ascended a total of 9 floors, shocking the disciples watching outside.

Furthermore, more and more disciples gathered at the tower to witness Min Li's spectacle after they learned that she was participating in the tower.

On the tenth floor, Min Li took a little over five minutes to pass that floor, as she'd to fight two magical beasts instead of one on the 10th floor.

Because the difficulty increased with each floor, especially every ten floors, Min Li needed more and more time to pass each floor as she ascended to the top, and by the time she reached the 19th floor, over 20 minutes had passed.

As for the 20th floor, it took her nearly 10 minutes to defeat.

Half an hour later, Min Li arrived at the 29th floor, and the 30th floor took her 15 minutes to defeat.

'This... this is taking much longer than I'd expected...' Yuan thought to himself after realizing how long it took to climb this tower. 'Guess I'll go get something to eat while she's inside.'

And with that in mind, Yuan left the scene to look for some food, as he didn't like the idea of just standing around and doing nothing.

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Chapter 140 - Dragon Pavilion

After leaving the area, Yuan went to the Dragon Pavilion that is known for its delicious food— at least that's what the guidebook claimed.

"This smell... is delicious!" Yuan's nose twitched with delight when he smelled a sweet and luscious aroma before he could even see the Dragon Pavilion, allowing him to reach the area without using his eyes.

A few minutes later, he arrived before this enormous pavilion that had round tables set up everywhere— both inside and outside of the pavilion, almost like a feast, and most of the tables were already occupied by disciples.

"Wow... this is a restaurant? I have never seen anything like this before." Yuan mumbled in a slightly dazed voice after seeing this place that looked more like a public gathering than anything.

"Hello, are you here to dine?" One of the disciples suddenly approached him and asked him.

"Huh?" Yuan looked at this young man wearing a banner over his Outer Court disciples' uniform that read 'Dragon Pavilion' with raised eyebrows.

"You work here? Even though you are a disciple?" Yuan couldn't help but ask him.

"Hm? You must be a new disciple if you're asking such a question. And yes, disciples can work in the sect for contribution points," said the disciple.

"I see..." Yuan nodded as he learned something new again.

"Anyway, are you going to eat here?" The disciple asked him again.

"Yes, I want to dine here," Yuan quickly nodded.

"Since you are a new disciple, I can only assume that you don't have a lot of contribution points, and the food here requires you to pay contribution points," said the disciple, and he continued, "If you want to use money, you'll have to go to the cafeteria, or you can pay other disciples who have contribution points."

"How much do they cost?" Yuan asked with slightly wide eyes. He has to use contribution points even for food?

"The common dishes generally cost around 1-5 contribution points while the most expensive ones are around 10 contribution points," said the disciple.

"Oh, then there's no problem," Yuan said with a calm look on his face.

"You're really going to eat here?" The disciple looked at Yuan with slight disbelief on his face.

Because the Dragon Pavilion is a luxury, almost all of the disciples that come to the Dragon Pavilion are wealthy disciples that have plenty of contribution points, and most new disciples would rather save their contribution points for something more meaningful than food such as cultivation techniques and cultivation resources.

"Yes," Yuan nodded.

"Umm... I should've mentioned this early but you also need 10 contribution points to reserve a table for an hour. If you stay longer than an hour, it'll be another 10 contribution points," said the disciple.

"That's fine." Yuan handed the disciple his gold identification token.

"G-Gold!" The disciple covered his mouth and exclaimed in a shocked voice after seeing Yuan's gold identification token.

"I-I am deeply sorry for not recognizing you, Senior!" The disciple quickly bowed to Yuan after realizing that he was before a bigshot with a gold

identification token.

"Uh... don't worry about it?" Yuan said with a puzzled look on his face.

"Please follow me, I'll bring you to our best table," said the disciple, and he proceeded to lead Yuan deeper into the pavilion.

Sometime later, they reached this secluded and small table that was surrounded by water with colorful fishes swimming within and beautiful flowers and giant water lilies floating around.

"Wow... what a peaceful and calming place," Yuan mumbled in a dazed voice as he could already feel his mood improving just from being in that atmosphere.

"Here's the menu, Senior. By the way, my name is Chu Bo," said the disciple as he handed a golden menu to Yuan after he sat down.

"This is it?" Yuan was surprised to see only a little over 20 items on the menu.

"Although there are not many choices, I can guarantee you that every dish on the menu is considered as a 'favorite' by every disciple that has dined here before," said Chu Bo.

"Furthermore, the menu changes every week."

"Then can I get everything on the menu?" Yuan said without hesitation a moment later.

"E-Everything?" Chu Bo looked at Yuan with wide eyes, and he continued, "The portions are not small, Senior. A single dish can feed two to four people."

"It'll be okay," Yuan said with a smile on his face. "I can handle it."

"I-I understand... That'll be a total of 124 contribution points..." Chu Bo said with his back feeling sweaty, as he cannot imagine spending 124 contribution points on food even if they taste extremely good.

Yuan handed Chu Bo his identification token. Once the contribution points were paid, Chu Bo bowed to Yuan and said, "Thank you, Senior, I'll be right back."

Once Chu Bo left the scene, Yuan turned to look at the water and watched the fishes swim around elegantly for a few minutes until he noticed a figure suddenly jumping towards the water and landing on one of the giant water lilies floating in the middle of the water, and this figure was a beautiful young lady holding what appeared to be an instrument in her fair hands.

"Woooo! I have been waiting for this!" Someone from the other side of the pavilion suddenly shouted.

"I came here today just to listen to Fairy Fei's music!"

"Me too! I cannot wait to hear Fairy Fei's zither music!"

Yuan raised his eyebrows after hearing the disciples from around the pavilion.

"A zither? She's going to play music with that large instrument?" Yuan mumbled to himself in a low voice after seeing this unfamiliar instrument, feeling an indescribable sensation in his heart afterward.

A moment later, this young lady wearing pink robes known as Fairy Fei sat down on the giant water lily with the instrument known as a zither placed on top of her lap, and after taking a deep breath, she placed her fingers on the thin strings and began playing music with it.

Chapter 141 - Fairy Fei's Zither Performance

Chapter 141 - Fairy Fei's Zither Performance

The moment Fairy Fei's finger released the string on the zither, a beautiful and clear music note that pulled people's heartstrings resounded in the area, even creating a single ripple on the water that moved like a small wave.

Yuan could feel his heart beating faster when he heard this music note, and his eyes narrowed at Fairy Fei's hands that danced elegantly and skillfully on the zither, ignoring her beautiful face and everything else while everyone else was focused on her facial expressions and beauty.

'What a unique sound and elegant performance... I can feel my mind calming down just from listening to her music,' Yuan thought to himself after watching Fairy Fei play the zither for a few minutes. If this Fairy Fei were to perform in his world, she would become an instant sensation around the world with her skills.

"Excuse me, Senior?" Chu Bo's voice suddenly resounded in Yuan's ears.

"Eh?" Yuan turned around to see Chu Bo standing behind him, and he quickly said, "Oh, I'm sorry. I was too absorbed in that young lady's performance."

"Haha... Don't worry about it, Senior. That's a natural reaction for everyone when they hear Fairy Fei play the zither for the first time," Chu Bo said, and he continued to explain, "Fairy Mei is actually a Core disciple who often comes to the Dragon Pavilion to practice her zither, allowing the guests to enjoy their food and listen to wonderful music at the same time. Of course, she's also getting paid contribution points for doing this so she benefits from it too."

"Anyway, your food will be ready in a few minutes, Senior. Please enjoy Fairy Fei's zither play in the meantime."

Yuan nodded and returned to watching Fairy Fei play the zither.

After watching Fairy Fei's hand movements for a few minutes and memorizing all of her movements, Yuan closed his eyes to fully indulge himself in the music.

"I see... so this is how you play the zither," Yuan mumbled to himself as he began imagining himself playing the zither inside his head, imitating Fairy Fei's hand movements while the sounds continued to flow into his ears.

If one could see inside Yuan's mind right now, they would be shocked to see that all of his hand movements replicated Fairy Fei's movements perfectly despite having his eyes closed.

After imagining himself playing the zither for a few minutes, Yuan began moving his hands for real, acting as though he was playing an invisible zither on his lap.

When Chu Bo saw this, his eyes widened with surprise, and then he turned to look at Fairy Fei's movements before he returned to looking at Yuan, comparing the two.

'Heavens! It feels almost like I am seeing Fairy Fei playing the zither before my very eyes when I am looking at him!' Chu Bo cried inwardly, nearly mistaking Yuan as Fairy Fei because of his precise and flawless hand movements.

'This Senior is also a zither expert? As expected of someone with a gold identification token!' Chu Bo wondered, completely unaware that Yuan is actually a beginner who didn't even know the existence of zithers until just a few minutes ago.

If Chu Bo had known this fact, who knows how he would react.

Sometime later, the food Yuan had ordered arrived at his table, and he began stuffing his face. However, while his eyes and mouth were focused on the food on the table, his ears and mind were completely focused on Fairy Fei's zither music.

Sometime later, once Yuan cleaned every single plate on the table with ease, he returned to watching Fairy Fei play the zither with a focused gaze, looking like how he would normally look when trying to learn a technique.

Meanwhile, Chu Bo cleaned the table with a startled look on his face, as he has never seen a single person eat so much food and so quickly before.

An hour passed within the blink of an eye since Yuan came to the Dragon Pavilion, and Chu Bo said to him, "Senior, your time in the Dragon Pavilion is up. However, if you'd like to extend for another hour, that'd be 10 contribution points."

"How long does she usually play for?" Yuan pointed at Fairy Fei and asked Chu Bo.

"It's mostly random, but usually between two to four hours," he responded. "There are even times when she'd practiced for an entire day without a break. I guess it all depends on her mood."

"I'd like to extend for another hour then," Yuan said as he handed another 10 contribution points to Chu Bo.

"Thank you, Senior." Chu Bo bowed to him afterward before he returned to standing in the corner to wait for Yuan's orders.

Meanwhile, Yuan returned to watching Fairy Fei's performance.

'I... kind of miss playing instruments...'

This thought suddenly appeared in Yuan's head after Fairy Fei finished another song.

'Even though I used to hate playing the instruments because mother and father always forced me to practice until my fingers bled, after becoming crippled and being unable to even hold an instrument for many years, I am beginning to miss them...' Yuan sighed inwardly.

After watching Fairy Fei for another hour, Yuan decided to leave the Dragon Pavilion and return to the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower

to see if Min Li was closed to finishing.

"How was your experience being at our Dragon Pavilion for the first time, Senior?" Chu Bo asked Yuan afterward.

"It was great," Yuan said to him, and he continued, "Especially that young lady's performance. Although there are some flaws, it was a delightful experience overall."

"Flaws...? Fairy Fei?" Chu Bo looked at Yuan with wide eyes, seemingly speechless.

Ting!

A sharp music note suddenly resounded, startling everybody that was fully indulged in the music, causing everybody there to turn to look at Fairy Fei who'd suddenly stopped playing the zither and was looking in a certain direction.

Fairy Fei suddenly stood up and carried the zither with her hands before jumping from the giant water lily.

Once she'd landed somewhere in the Dragon Pavilion, she narrowed her eyes at a handsome young man a few meters away and spoke in a cold voice, "I heard what you'd said just now— that my performance is flawed? I would love to listen to the reasoning behind your words... Outer Court disciple."

'Oh, shit...' Chu Bo unconsciously took a few steps backward when Fairy Fei suddenly appeared before them.

Chapter 142 - Playing The Zither

"You, who claimed that my zither performance was flawed... What is the reasoning behind such claims? Are you also a zither expert? What qualifications do you have to call me out?" Fairy Fei looked at Yuan with narrowed eyes while she stood on the thin railings with perfect balance.

"Qualifications?" Yuan raised his eyebrows, and then he said, "Although I am not a zither expert, I don't need to be a zither expert to tell that you had made several mistakes in your playing in the last hour. As long as I have enough experience in music, I can tell if something is amiss just by the notes and flow alone, and there were several notes that didn't flow properly during your performance."

'T-This disciple...' Fairy Fei clenched her teeth tightly after hearing Yuan's words and her eyebrows twitched uncontrollably, but she was not angry at him. In fact, she was surprised that Yuan had managed to notice her mistakes, even feeling a little bit nervous since she has never been caught or called out before, as everyone would just assume that she was perfect.

However, she did not want to admit that she— a Core disciple— was wrong right before two Outer Court disciples.

"What is your name?" Fairy Fei suddenly asked him after a moment of silence.

"Yuan," he calmly responded.

"Disciple Yuan, right? Since you are so confident that my performance was flawed, why don't you show me how it's done?" Fairy Fei then laid her zither on the table and stared at Yuan with a serious look on her elegant

face. "You have 'experience' in music, right? Surely, you will be able to play the zither better than me if that is the case."

"Uhh..." Yuan looked at the beautiful zither that seemed to be made of some kind of wood laying on the table with a somewhat dazed look on his face.

Although he has never played the zither before, he was not someone who would shy away from something they have never experienced before, especially when it was related to music and instruments. After all, how else will he learn them if not by playing with them?

'That's what I thought! Even though you may have a sharp intuition for music, you don't have what it takes to play the zither!' Fairy Fei smiled inwardly after seeing Yuan's dazed face.

Of course, she'd rather if Yuan didn't actually play the zither, as she wouldn't know what to do if he really played the zither better than her.

However, little did Fairy Fei know that she'd already dug a deep hole for herself by giving an instrument to Yuan who was widely recognized by the whole world to be the number one prodigy in history in the field of music.

And when Fairy Fei saw Yuan reaching for the zither, she cried inwardly, 'He's actually going to play the zither?!'

Fairy Fei frowned before speaking out loud, "Wait a second!"

"What's the matter?" Yuan looked at her with an innocent look on his face, and he continued, "You want me to play the zither, right? Although I have never played it before, I should be able to play it to some extent."

"Eh? You have never played the zither before?" Fairy Fei looked at him with her clear eyes wide open, as did Chu Bo who thought he was definitely an expert.

"Ahem!"

After a moment of silence, Fairy Fei cleared her throat before speaking in a somewhat stiff voice, "N-Never mind! You can go ahead and play the

zither."

"Okay." Yuan nodded and pulled the zither closer before sitting back down.

Yuan then closed his eyes to practice a little bit more inside his head.

A few moments later, Yuan opened his eyes again and took a deep breath before he slowly lifted his hands like he was prepared to play the piano.

'Such calm movements... I would've never thought this would be his first time if he didn't say it...' Fairy Fei frowned when she saw Yuan's arm movements before he even began playing the zither.

Yuan's finger gently touched one of the strings on the zither, and a single later—

Ting~

An extremely crisp and beautiful sound echoed in the place, creating a calm ripple on the water while causing Fairy Fei's heart to skip a beat at the same time.

Another note immediate followed afterward—

Ting~

Yuan began playing the zither with precise movements like a real expert who had years of experience with the instrument, replaying one of Fairy Fei's earlier songs.

Fairy Fei's jaw dropped when she saw this, and she cried inwardly, 'T-This damn brat lied to me! How dare you say this is your first time playing the zither when you can produce such flawless notes?!'

Meanwhile, when the other guests at the Dragon Pavilion realized the music had returned, they immediately mistook Yuan's zither play for Fairy Fei's zither play.

"Where's Fairy Fei playing from? Why did she suddenly move locations?"

"Who cares where she's playing from— this music is amazing! In fact, I think it sounds even better than just a few moments ago!"

"Perhaps Fairy Fei found a new favorite spot, enhancing her performance."

"..."

When Fairy Fei heard the other guests' words, she nearly puked out a mouthful of blood on the spot but somehow managed to resist it by clenching her teeth tightly together.

'Just who is this Outer Court disciple?! If he can dine in this place, he's definitely no ordinary individual! However, I don't recognize him at all!' Fairy Fei pondered to herself with a deep frown on her face.

The only thing keeping Fairy Fei from losing her temperament was Yuan's unknown identity. Even though Yuan is only a mere Outer Court disciple, Fairy Fei knew very well that one's outer appearance can be very deceiving and that she shouldn't judge someone just by their looks. After all, no sane Outer Court disciple would be able to keep calm before a Core disciple, much less challenge them in such a manner!

Chapter 143 - Completely Absorbed In Yuan's Performance

Chapter 143 - Completely Absorbed In Yuan's Performance

Ting~

The music notes from the zither flowed throughout the entire Dragon Pavilion, sounding as though the heavens were singing, and Yuan progressively got better at playing the zither the longer he played it.

Within minutes after he touched his first zither, Yuan's skills and movements have already drastically changed, even playing the zither in his own style.

This shocked Fairy Fei, who cried inwardly, 'His hand movements have changed! It looked like he was copying my style at first, but he suddenly started using his own style! What does this mean? Is this really his first time playing the zither? But... that's impossible!'

A few more minutes later, after playing the final music note in the song, Yuan stopped moving his hands and turned to look at Fairy Fei before speaking, "What do you think? Although it was a bit rough, I have managed to play the song properly."

'Rough?! You call that performance 'rough'?!' Both Chu Bo and Fairy Fei cried inwardly after hearing his words.

"..."

Fairy Fei stared at Yuan with a profound frown on her face, and she spoke after a moment of silence, "Play it again."

"Excuse me?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"I said play the zither again. You said I had several flaws in my performance, right? Well, you're going to play every single song that I'd made a mistake in for me."

"Uhhh... I don't mind, but my time at the Dragon Pavilion is already up..." Yuan said, mostly because he also wanted to play the zither for a little bit longer after finding out how entertaining it was.

Fairy Fei then turned to look at Chu Bo before speaking, "I will pay for his extra time."

"Y-Yes, Senior apprentice-sister!" Chu Bo nodded nervously.

"You can stay here as long as necessary now," Fairy Fei said after she returned to looking at Yuan.

Yuan nodded and continued to play the zither a moment later, playing a completely different song this time.

Ting~

'This is my original song, Swan Flying Above the Heavens! Let's see if he can play it properly!' Fairy Fei proceeded to stare at Yuan with a sharp gaze and without blinking, almost like she couldn't afford to miss even the slightest movement from him.

However, the longer she listened to Yuan play, the more Fairy Fei admired Yuan's skills, especially his hand movements, even feeling a little bit agitated that Yuan was playing her original song better than herself!

As for Yuan, the more he played with the zither the more comfortable he got with the instrument, and he even started to play the zither with his eyes closed midway through the third song.

Ting~

Once Yuan began playing his fourth song, Fairy Fei took a seat next to him and closed her eyes, fully indulging herself in Yuan's zither play.

Very quickly, Fairy Fei found herself completely absorbed in Yuan's performance, feeling as though each music note played by Yuan was massaging her body and mind.

The other guests in the Dragon Pavilion also felt the same, and most of them had even stopped eating their food to fully focus on the music.

"Did Fairy Fei reach a new level with her zither? I have listened to her zither play many times before but this is the first time I am feeling this way..."

"Yes... I can feel a warm sensation all over my body just from listening to this music... I wouldn't mind spending all of my contribution points if I can listen to this a little bit longer..."

A little over an hour later, Yuan finished his 7th and final song.

"I am finished," Yuan turned to look at Fairy Fei and said to her afterward.

However, there was no response from Fairy Fei who was sitting beside him with her eyes still closed, seemingly asleep.

"Uhhh..." Yuan didn't want to disturb her peaceful mood, so he stood up and quietly walked away.

"A-Are you really going to leave her like this?" Chu Bo asked Yuan in a low and nervous voice when he noticed that Yuan was leaving.

"Yes, I have somewhere that I need to be," Yuan responded, and he said, "The food was really good. I'll definitely return when I have the time."

Once Yuan left the Dragon Pavilion, Chu Bo remained standing in the same spot and patiently waited for Fairy Fei to open her eyes again.

However, unbeknownst to Chu Bo, Fairy Fei was actually experiencing enlightenment at this very moment after listening to Yuan play the zither, hence why she remained still even many hours later.

By the time Fairy Fei opened her eyes again, Yuan was already long gone.

'To think I'd experience enlightenment from that Outer Court disciple's performance... Just who is this young man?' Fairy Fei wondered to herself after she emerged from her enlightenment, feeling as though her comprehension with the zither went up by a whole level.

"W-Where did that disciple go?!" Fairy Fei asked Chu Bo with a dumbfounded look on her face when she realized that Yuan had disappeared.

"T-That disciple has already left... six hours ago..." Chu Bo responded with a sweaty back.

"What?! He actually disappeared without a word?! And you just let him leave?!" Fairy Fei slammed the table with her palms, causing it to tremble.

"I-I'm sorry, Senior apprentice-sister... I thought you wouldn't mind, and I didn't dare to make him stay for too long," Chu Bo quickly apologized.

"What was that disciple's name again?" Fairy Fei then asked with a frown on her face.

"Disciple Yuan."

"Disciple Yuan... Do you know anything about him? His background? Anything at all!" Fairy Fei asked Chu Bo.

"N-No..." Chu Bo quickly shook his head. "I only know that this is his first time at the Dragon Pavilion and that he's a new disciple."

"First time at the Dragon Pavilion?! So he listened to my songs for the first time today?! And he somehow managed to play it so perfectly?!" Fairy Fei's jaw dropped to the floor when she realized the real situation.

'Disciple Yuan... Disciple Yuan... Just who are you?' Fairy Fei stared at the zither on the table that had a lonely aura to it, almost like the zither was also upset that Yuan had left it behind.

Chapter 144 - I Want To Know More About Him!

"I ended up staying at the Dragon Pavilion for longer than I'd intended... I hope I don't get scolded for suddenly disappearing after signing up for the challenge..." Yuan mumbled to himself as he power-walked back to the Carp Leaping Over the Dragon's Gate Tower after leaving the Dragon Pavilion, silently hoping that Min Li was still inside the tower.

"What the heck?"

When Yuan returned to the tower, he was shocked by the progress Min Li had made during the 3 hours that he'd disappeared, and to his surprise, Min Li was only on the 43rd floor!

'It took her over three hours to progress a little over 10 floors?! Just long will this challenge take?' Yuan cried inwardly.

After standing around for a few more moments, Yuan approached one of the nearby disciples before asking him, "Excuse me, fellow disciple. How long does it usually take for one to come out of the tower?"

The disciple looked at Yuan before speaking, "Well, it depends on how far they climb. Most people will come out after a couple of hours. However, because this is Fairy Min that we're talking about, it'll probably take a few more days before she comes out."

"A few days?!" Yuan's eyes widened with shock after hearing this, as he truly didn't expect it would take this long.

The disciple nodded and said, "Some disciples even stay inside the tower for an entire week, as they spend all 15 minutes to rest on each floor after defeating it."

'If I knew it'd take this long, I would have stayed at the Dragon Pavilion to play the zither some more!' Yuan sighed inwardly.

'Oh well... Guess I'll cultivate in the real world while I wait for Disciple Min to come out.'

With that in mind, Yuan logged off the game and began cultivating in the real world.

Meanwhile, news of Fairy Fei's breakthrough spread throughout the sect like wildfire, causing the Dragon Pavilion to have an influx of guests for the next few days as everybody and their mother wanted to listen to Fairy Fei's zither play.

However, to the disciples' disappointment, Fairy Fei stopped showing up at the Dragon Pavilion for an entire week after her 'breakthrough' even though she would normally show up twice a week.

As for what Fairy Fei was doing during this time, she went around the sect looking for information about a new Outer Court disciple named 'Yuan', but alas, no matter how much she searched or how many sect elders she asked, none of them seemed to know a disciple named Yuan.

"How is it possible that nobody knows him? If he can dine at the Dragon Pavilion, surely he must be someone with important background. Furthermore, the disciple who served him said that he had a golden identification token!" Fairy Fei sighed, feeling dejected that she could not learn anything about Yuan.

"What's the matter, Disciple Fei?"

A mature figure suddenly approached Fairy Fei from behind and asked her.

Fairy Fei turned around to see Elder Shan standing behind her.

"Disciple greets Master Shan!" Fairy Fei greeted her.

Elder Shan nodded and continued, "You seem to have a lot on your mind. Perhaps I can assist you."

"Do you know of a disciple by the name of 'Yuan'?" Fairy Fei asked her. "I have asked multiple sect elders already, but none of them seem to know this Outer Court disciple."

'Y-Yuan...?' Elder Shan looked at Fairy Fei with wide eyes. How did Yuan attract a Core disciple's attention already?

"Can you tell me a little bit more? Why are you bothering yourself with an Outer Court disciple?" Elder Shan asked her a moment later, pretending as though she didn't know Yuan, and she was curious about her disciple's relationship with Yuan.

"Well... this happened at the Dragon Pavilion not long ago..."

Fairy Fei proceeded to recall what happened at the Dragon Pavilion to Elder Shan. She spoke of Yuan's characteristics, his seemingly unfathomable background, and his amazing zither skills that'd helped her gain enlightenment.

Elder Shan listened to Fairy Fei with a loose jaw, as she would've never imagined that such a thing could've happened between the two of them.

'Yuan is not only a cultivation expert but also a genius with the zither? And to think Disciple Fei, a Core disciple, would receive enlightenment from listening to his zither music... Just what kind of entity is he?' Elder Shan wondered to herself.

"What do you think, Master Shan? Do you know of this disciple?" Fairy Fei asked again afterward.

A profound smile appeared on Elder Shan's face, and she spoke, "Who knows? Maybe I do, maybe I don't. If this Outer Court disciple is as amazing as you described him to be, you'll definitely meet him again in the

future. Anyway, I am currently very busy running errands for the Sect Master. I'll talk to you later, Disciple Fei."

And without giving Fairy Fei a chance to respond, Elder Shan disappeared from the place, dumbfounding Fairy Fei.

"So Master Shan knows this Outer Court disciple... but why isn't she telling me anything and purposefully hiding his identity? I want to know more about him! No... I need to know more!" Fairy Fei mumbled to herself in a resolute voice, as she feared that she might not be able to sleep peacefully if her curiosity for Yuan's mysterious background is not settled.

Meanwhile, after cultivating for two days straight in the real world, Yuan returned to the cultivation world to see where Min Li was at for the tower.

"76 floors?" Yuan mumbled after seeing a golden light coming from the 75th floor, indicating that Min Li had passed that floor.

"Look! Fairy Min did it! She actually managed to pass 75 floors in the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower! And she's still only a Spirit Apprentice!"

"Hahaha! I'm so glad that I dropped everything I was doing to come here to witness this grand occasion!"

"As expected of Fairy Min! Her talent is simply otherworldly! She will definitely have a limitless future!"

The disciples there celebrated Min Li's achievements as though it was their own.

Chapter 145 - Challenging The Tower

Another hour after Min Li reached the 75th floor, a golden light emitted from the 77th floor, indicating that she had passed that floor as well.

"Wow! 77 floors on her first try! As expected of Fairy Min!"

"She has taken first place in the rankings! Fairy Min is currently the highest climber out of all Outer Court disciples!"

"I find it crazy how she'd decided to challenge the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower only two days after she'd become a disciple! Only someone from one of the Seven Legacy Families would dare to be so bold and confident in their abilities!"

However, little did these disciples know that the reason Min Li challenged the tower was not because of the tower itself but because of a certain Outer Court disciple! Furthermore, this Outer Court disciple had left midway through her challenge to eat food and play the zither!

If Min Li knew that Yuan had cared so little about her performance, it would definitely deal a lot of damage to her confidence and pride.

About another half an hour later, the 78th floor glowed a bright light. However, it was not a golden color like everyone had expected but a bright red color instead.

"Oh no! Fairy Min could not pass the 78th floor!"

All of the disciples there released a saddened noise after seeing this red light.

'Does this mean she's finally finished?' Yuan thought to himself.

A few minutes later, the door to the tower opened, and Min Li slowly walked out with messy hair and shabby clothes, looking very similar to the disciple that had challenged the tower before her.

When the disciples there saw her rough appearance, they immediately approached her with medicines and recovery pills in their hands.

"Congratulations on passing the 77th floor and reaching 1st place, Fairy Min! You are now guaranteed to become a Core disciple once your cultivation base reaches the Spirit Warrior realm!"

"You can have this high-quality recovery pill, Fairy Min! It'll instantly heal all of your injuries and restore your spiritual energy!"

"Do you want some water, Fairy Min? I happen to have some right here..."

"Give me a break!" Min Li suddenly shouted, causing the disciples around her to scramble away after staring at her for a good two seconds.

Once she finally had some room to breathe, Min Li retrieved a white pill from her Spatial Ring and tossed it into her mouth before she drank some water.

A few moments later, the small injuries on her face and limbs began disappearing, and even her breathing gradually became calm again.

After she'd made a complete recovery, Min Li searched the crowd for a certain individual. Once she saw Yuan's face, a prideful smile appeared on her face.

'Let's see if you can beat me and how long it'll take you!' she said to herself inwardly.

Seeing Min Li smiling at him, Yuan thought to himself, 'It should be my turn to challenge the tower now, right? After all, I did register my name after Disciple Min...'

After pondering for a moment, he decided to enter the tower while everyone else was still focused on Min Li, sneaking into the tower without attracting anyone's attention— except Min Li who had kept her gaze on him the entire time.

"Eh? Did someone just enter the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower just now? Who was it?" One of the disciples there suddenly said when he noticed the door close behind him.

"Who cares, honestly. I'd only come here for Fairy Min and nobody else!"

'He went inside!' Min Li thought to herself after seeing Yuan enter the tower.

"How about a celebration at the Dragon Pavilion, Fairy Min? It'll be my treat, of course."

A few handsome-looking Inner Court disciples approached Min Li and offered her free food at the Dragon Pavilion, yet Min Li didn't even bother to glance at them and said, "No thank you, I am busy right now."

"Busy, you say?"

The Inner Court disciples were dumbfounded by her response. Other than standing there and staring at the tower, she didn't look 'busy' at all.

Meanwhile, inside the tower, Yuan had just arrived on the first floor that was more spacious than it appeared from the outside, resembling an empty dojo.

«Welcome to Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower!»

A notification appeared before Yuan a few moments after he entered the tower.

«Initializing Character Evaluation»

«Character Evaluation Completed»

«The Tower's difficulty has been adjusted to 'Dragon'»

"Dragon?" Yuan raised his eyebrows when he saw the difficulty. He wondered how difficult 'Dragon' was, how many difficulties existed in this challenge, and what difficulty Min Li had to deal with.

A few moments later, a list of rules appeared before Yuan.

«Dragon Difficulty»

«Challenger has 10 minutes to pass each floor or the Challenger will automatically fail»

«Challenger is limited to 15 minutes of rest for every 10 floors»

«Magical Beasts will start from '1st level Spirit Warrior'»

«Magical Beasts are extra study»

«Magical Beasts are extra powerful»

«Magical Beasts will have significantly increased strength, speed, and defense»

«A powerful Magical Beast will appear every ten floors»

«All medicine, pills, and resources that affect the Challenger's body or cultivation will be restricted»

A few moments later, Yuan could feel his suppressed aura returning to normal, most likely because the tower had sealed the Pill of Concealment—not that it affected Yuan in any way because his cultivation didn't change.

«Trial will begin in 30 seconds»

In those thirty seconds, Yuan prepared himself by retrieving both of his Soul Weapons, wielding the Empyrean Overlord with his hands, and controlling the Starry Abyss with the Flying Dagger technique, allowing him to use both Soul Weapons simultaneously.

Once the thirty seconds were up, an ape-like magical beast suddenly appeared in the middle of the and roared, emitting an aura that was equivalent to a Cultivator at the 1st level Spirit Warrior realm.

However, Yuan didn't even blink from the pressure it emitted and immediately controlled his Starry Abyss to strike the magical beast like it was a Training Puppet.

Whoosh!

Boom!

A gaping space appeared in the magical beast's head as the Starry Abyss ripped a clean hole in its face with ease, clearly the first floor in less than three seconds!

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Chapter 146 - 20th Floor

«You have passed the 1st floor. Please ascend to the next floor within 10 seconds or you will automatically fail the trial.»

"What? That was easy..." Yuan mumbled to himself in a surprised tone when he defeated the monster with such ease. "Well, this is the first floor, after all..."

A few seconds later, Yuan ascended to the next floor by walking up the staircase not far away from him.

However, he didn't immediately reach the 2nd floor and entered the resting area that was between the first and second floor instead.

«You have entered the resting area. The timer will begin when you begin to cultivate.»

Yuan ignored the resting area and proceeded to the 2nd floor.

Meanwhile, outside the tower, the disciples there were dumbfounded when the first floor glowed a golden light so quickly.

"What? Whoever is inside has already passed the first floor? But that's too quickly even for the first floor! Not even Fairy Min cleared it that fast!"

The disciples outside were dumbfounded by what they had witnessed.

"Maybe that disciple had used his most powerful technique from the start? That would explain it."

"What a waste of energy!"

"Hahaha! What an idiot! Who uses their strongest attack on the first floor?"

However, not even a minute later, the second floor glowed a golden light.

"What?! He'd passed another floor so quickly already?! Is he trying to exhaust all of his spiritual energy before he reaches the tenth floor?!"

Half a minute later—

"Another one! He's on the third floor already!"

Another half a minute later—

"Again?! This disciple clearly doesn't understand how the tower works!"

The disciples were slightly shocked, as they cannot imagine what must be going through the mind of the disciple challenging the tower right now.

Three more minutes later, the ninth floor glowed a golden light.

"Heavens... This disciple... He's not even taking any breaks in-between each floor!"

"Hahaha! I'll give him 20 floors maximum before he gets kicked out of the tower for exhausting his energy!"

"20? You're being too generous! I bet that idiot won't even make it past the 10th floor!"

"Hahaha!"

While the disciples laughed merrily outside the tower, inside the tower, Yuan had just stepped onto the tenth floor.

«You have 10 minutes to defeat the Magical Beasts»

Once the magical beasts appeared— two of them for the first time, the timer began.

«9:59»

«9:58»

«9:57»

«9:56»

"Two monsters, huh? They're still only at the 2nd level Spirit Warrior realm, though."

Yuan then controlled the Starry Abyss to kill one of the magical beasts while he pounced at the second magical beast with the Empyrean Overlord raised.

"Bloody Sword Strike!"

The large sword glowed a red color, and—

Whoosh!

The entire floor shook when Yuan sliced the magical beast in half like a sharp knife cutting through tofu before hitting the floor. However, there was surprisingly no damage done to the floor despite being struck by Yuan, which is one of the reasons why Yuan hasn't been minding his own strength too much.

After passing the 10th floor, Yuan continued to the 11th floor.

«Congratulations on reaching 10 floors. The difficulty has been adjusted.»

«Magical Beasts will now have 'Weak Regeneration'»

«Magical Beasts will have their power, speed, and defenses increased slightly»

«The trail for the 11th floor will begin in 10 seconds»

A massive green mantis appeared in the center of the room ten seconds later and stared at Yuan with an intimidating gaze while emitting an aura close to the 4th level of the Spirit Warrior realm.

'From the second level to the fourth level? I might have to fight Spirit Masters later at the higher floors...' Yuan swallowed nervously before controlling the Starry Abyss to attack the green mantis.

Whoosh!

However, to his surprise, the green mantis was defeated as easily as the monsters from the previous floors.

'Maybe it's not as difficult as it appears...' Yuan thought to himself as he continued to ascend the tower with relative ease, and he proceeded to slay the magical beasts on each floor with the same speed as he did from floors one to ten.

When the disciples saw how quickly Yuan ascended from the 11th floor to the 20th floor, they were all gobsmacked.

"Good lord! Where is this disciple getting his energy from?! He rushed from the 1st floor to the 20th floor in less than 10 minutes! That's freaking ridiculous!"

'Disciple Yuan...' Min Li stared at the tower that was one-fifth lit up with golden lights with a nervous frown on her face.

'20 floors in 10 minutes... Are you really that confident in your own abilities or are you simply being reckless?' she wondered to herself.

Meanwhile, on the 20th floor, Yuan did not immediately attack the magical beasts that had just spawned and merely looked at them with a surprised look on his face, as he'd seen these monsters before.

"Demonic Spiders? Two of them at the 5th level Spirit Warrior realm?"

Seeing these two Demonic Spiders, Yuan immediately recalled what happened not long ago at the Demonic Spider Silent Cave and sighed, "If

only I was able to save that man's daughter..."

A few seconds later, Yuan rushed at the Demonic Spiders without using the Starry Abyss or the Flying Daggers technique, as he had a personal grudge with Demonic Spiders and he wanted to vent a little.

BOOM!

The entire floor shook violently as Yuan tore apart one of the Demonic Spiders with ease.

After killing the first Demonic Spider, Yuan turned to look at the second with a calm but slightly cold look on his face.

"To think I was somewhat fearful of you not too long ago..." Yuan mumbled in a low voice as he casually approached the Demonic Spider that could not speak like the one he'd encountered outside.

"Kaaaa!"

The Demonic Spider quickly raised its front legs that resembled scythes and slashed them at Yuan's face.

Whoosh!

Yuan used the phoenix movement technique to dodge the incoming attacks with ease before appearing behind the Demonic Spider.

"Die!"

Boom!

The floor shook once again as Yuan slashed the Demonic Spider with the Empyrean Overlord vertically, slicing it cleanly in half.

«You have passed the 20th floor»

Chapter 147 - This Place Is Now Off Limits!

After reaching the 21st floor, the difficulty adjusted once again.

«Congratulations on reaching a total of 20 floors. The difficulty has been adjusted.»

«Magical Beasts will now have 'Weak Physical Damage Resistance'»

«Magical Beasts will have their power, speed, and defenses increased slightly»

When Yuan saw the notification this time, he didn't react much and patiently waited for the magical beasts to spawn.

Ten seconds later, a magical beast with an aura at the 6th level Spirit Warrior realm spawned in the middle of the room, and Yuan immediately slew it with the Starry Abyss like usual.

Half a minute later, he cleared the 22nd floor.

Another half a minute later, the 23rd floor glowed with a golden light.

24... 25... 26...

Yuan arrived at the 30th floor five minutes later and then defeated the two 7th level Spirit Warrior magical beasts there within a single minute, ascending to the 31st floor.

«Congratulations on reaching a total of 30 floors. The difficulty has been adjusted.»

«Magical Beasts will now have 'Weak Spiritual Damage Resistance'»

«Magical Beasts will have their power, speed, and defenses increased slightly»

However, despite the difficulty adjustments, Yuan didn't feel its effects, almost like there were no changes at all, and he continued to ascend the tower at record-breaking speeds.

After spending a total of 30 minutes inside the tower, Yuan has managed to reach the 51st floor after defeating the magical beasts on the 50th floor that were at the 9th level of the Spirit Warrior realm, climbing half of the tower.

«Congratulations on reaching a total of 50 floors. The difficulty has been adjusted.»

«Magical Beasts will now have 'Moderate Regeneration'»

«Magical Beasts will now have 'Moderate Physical Damage Resistance'»

«Magical Beasts will now have 'Moderate Spiritual Damage Resistance'»

«Magical Beasts will have their power, speed, and defenses increased moderately»

Yuan expected the monsters on the 51st floor and onward to be at the Spirit Master realm, but to his surprise, the monsters remained at the peak of the Spirit Realm even after the 60th floor.

"Maybe the tower is only limited to monsters below the Spirit Warrior level? That would make sense since most disciples are only Spirit Apprentices and it would be ridiculous if the tower makes these Spirit Apprentices fight Spirit Masters..."

Thus, Yuan continued speeding through the rest of the tower with barely any breaks in-between the floors, and he only began taking breaks before the boss room after reaching the 70th floor, mainly because the trial was so easy that he'd gotten bored of it.

Meanwhile, outside the tower, hundreds of disciples stared at the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gates Tower that had 75 floors glowing with a golden color with gawking expressions on their faces, as they have never witnessed such an incredible sight before.

Furthermore, none of the disciples there have spoken a single word after Yuan passed the 50th floor, and they only stared in silence as they witnessed an unprecedented event.

'This Disciple Yuan... Damn it! Why are you so damn talented?! This isn't fair!' Min Li cried inwardly when Yuan passed her record and ascended to the 78th floor.

Yuan's performance at the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gates Tower was so shocking that it'd reached the ears of most disciples in the sect and even many sect elders, causing more people to show up at the tower to witness the spectacle.

"What? Some unknown disciple managed to ascend over 70 floors in less than an hour? How is that fucking possible?" One of the sect elders directly cursed when he heard this news.

Another sect elder directly spat the tea in his mouth back out when he learned about the situation.

"Fuck! Did a Core disciple sneak inside the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gates in the Outer Court or something? I don't believe that an Outer Court disciple will be able to achieve such feats!"

The news had spread so fast that it reached even the ears of Long Yijun and the other high-ranking sect elders.

"What? Who could possibly..."

When Long Yijun wondered which disciple was responsible for this commotion, the image of Yuan's face immediately appeared in his head, causing him to facepalm loudly.

Pa!

'It's definitely Disciple Yuan! I cannot imagine anyone else doing anything close to this!' Long Yijun thought to himself, and he decided to personally head to the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gates Tower.

"This is definitely Disciple Yuan's doing..." Elder Xuan sighed when he heard the news from Bai Ling.

"What should we do?" Bai Ling asked.

"Fortunately for us, nobody seems to know who is challenging the tower so we can still avoid Disciple Yuan's identity and talent from being leaked before the Mystic Realm. However, we won't be able to hide the fact that a disciple with monstrous talents has appeared in our sect, so we need to prepare for that." Elder Xuan said.

And he continued, "I'm sure the Sect Master is already heading to the tower as we speak, but I'll also go just in case."

"I'll come along too," said Bai Ling.

Thus, Long Yijun and many high-ranking sect elders appeared at the tower sometime later, and by the time they arrived at the tower, there were less than ten floors left in the tower, leaving them speechless.

'Heavens... Don't tell me he's going to set another precedent by becoming the first person to defeat all 100 floors in the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gates Tower? Even the Founder only managed to pass 99 floors!' Long Yijun cried inwardly as a golden light emitted from the 94th floor.

Once Yuan stepped onto the 95th floor, Long Yijun and the other high-ranking sect elders began dispersing the crowd at the place, as they didn't want Yuan's identity to leak so quickly.

"This place is now off limits! You all have 30 seconds to disappear from my sight or I will punish you for disobeying my—the Sect Master's direct

orders!" Long Yijun's voice boomed in the area, startling the disciples there.

"You heard the Sect Master! Everyone, scram!" Bai Ling also shouted at them.

Very quickly, the disciples there began scattering like a group of scared ants, disappearing from the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gates Tower and emptying out the area in the time it would take Yuan to finish many floors — less than a minute.

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Chapter 148 - The 100th Floor

Once all of the disciples left the scene with the sect elders remaining, Long Yijun turned to look at the low-ranking sect elders and shouted, "This includes the sect elders! Or are you trying to tell me that you're not disciples?!"

The sect elders there immediately began sweating and ran away in a hurry, silently wondering to themselves why they couldn't be there as well.

"What the heck? We're sect elders, right? Why can't we be there as well?" One of them asked after they were all very far away from the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower.

"Why are you asking us? Do we look like the Sect Master to you?" Another one said.

"Haaa... I wanted to know who was inside that tower, though."

"What about the record book? Surely, we can find out if we look at whoever signed up for the tower, right?"

"You're right! There's the record book! Who is in charge of that this week?"

"That would be Elder Bao, right? But I don't see him here."

Meanwhile, the disciples were also complaining to each other—

"Why were we chased away? What's wrong with seeing the person inside the tower?"

"Who knows. Maybe you should ask the Sect Master afterward."

"Do you think I have a fucking death wish?!"

"We'll eventually find out. There's no way someone so talented can be kept hidden for long."

Back at the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower, Long Yijun and the other high-ranking sect elders there all stared at a middle-aged man who was soaking in cold sweats at this moment.

"Let me see the record book." Long Yijun extended his hand to the sect elder who managed the records.

"Here you go, Sect Master..." Elder Bao handed the book to Long Yijun with trembling hands, and he recalled how he'd disrespected the young Outer Court disciple who signed up after Min Li.

'Fuck, fuck, fuck! I am so fucking dead! If they learn that I've offended the person inside the tower right now, they will eat me alive!' Elder Bao cried inwardly, feeling like he'd fall unconscious from fear at any moment.

A few moments later, Long Yijun mumbled, "I knew it... It's Disciple Yuan that's inside right now."

"Did you even need to look at the book, Sect Master? I'm pretty sure we already knew..." Elder Shan said with a smile on her face, and she turned to look at the tower and continued to speak, "Do you think he'll achieve 100 floors?"

"We already know that he's more talented than the Founder so that's very likely," said Elder Xuan.

"Anyway, you are Sect Elder Bao, right?" Bai Ling approached him and asked.

"T-That's right!" Elder Bao quickly nodded.

Bai Ling then placed his large hands onto Elder Bao's shoulders firmly before speaking in a serious and deep voice, "I want you to listen to me very carefully, Elder Bao. The disciple who entered this tower— Disciple

Yuan— you will not reveal any information about him no matter what! In fact, you can forget about what happened here today, do you understand me?"

Elder Bao immediately nodded his head, shaking his sweat all over the place.

However, Elder Shan approached them and said, "I don't think he understands, Elder Bai. We need to ensure that he doesn't forget it by next week..."

Elder Bao looked at Elder Shan's beautiful face with wide eyes filled with shock and fear. What is she going to do with him?

"You don't have to bully him, Elder Shan. I'm sure we can trust Elder Bao to keep something this small as a secret. After all, he wouldn't be a sect elder if he couldn't." Xin Ming shook his head and said to her, subtly threatening Elder Bao's position as sect elder.

"I won't say anything! I swear, Seniors! I didn't see or hear anything today! In fact, I wasn't even here today! Disciple who? I don't even know what you're talking about!" Elder Bao quickly exclaimed, feeling as though there were knives around his neck at this moment, and a single wrong word might get him killed.

"See? Elder Bao understands." Xin Ming laughed out loud afterward.

"Whatever." Elder Shan no longer cared about Elder Bao and turned around to continue watching the tower.

"You may leave now, Elder Bao." Long Yijun said to him who immediately scrambled away in a heartbeat, like a rabbit running away from a group of tigers and lions.

"So this is the Disciple Yuan that I have been hearing so much about from you guys. I thought you were all exaggerating, but alas, it seems like I am still a frog in a well..." One of the high-ranking sect elders there suddenly spoke, as he wasn't there when Yuan introduced himself.

"Welcome to Disciple Yuan's talent show, Elder Zou. Just wait until he clears the 100th floor— that's when the real show begins." Elder Shan chuckled in a cute manner.

Meanwhile, inside the tower, Yuan has just reached the 99th floor.

«Congratulations on reaching the 99th floor. The difficulty has been adjusted.»

«Magical Beasts will now have 'Superior Regeneration'»

«Magical Beasts will now have 'Superior Physical Damage Resistance'»

«Magical Beasts will now have 'Superior Spiritual Damage Resistance'»

«Magical Beasts will now have 'Powerful Intimidation Aura'»

«Magical Beasts will now have 'Powerful Damage Mitigation'»

«Magical Beasts will have their power, speed, and defenses increased significantly»

«The number of Magical Beasts in the room has increased to 99»

"99 monsters this time, huh?" Yuan smiled bitterly when the number of monsters doubled compared to the previous floor, and they were all at the peak of the Spirit Warrior realm.

Yuan raised the Empyrean Overlord and charged at the group of magical beasts with a calm expression on his face, and the Starry Abyss followed him from behind for a second before it shot itself forward and began slaying the magical beasts with ease.

A couple of minutes later, all 99 magical beasts were slain by Yuan.

«You have passed floor 99! Proceed to the final floor and prepare to challenge the Great One!»

Yuan's eyebrows raised in a surprised manner when he saw this notification.

"The Great One? I'll have to fight that Dragon? Are you kidding me?! How am I supposed to defeat a Dragon that's countless times larger than myself and can even destroy stars with a mere gaze?!" Yuan cried out loud.

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Chapter 149 - The Great One's Challenge

Chapter 149 - The Great One's Challenge

"Look! Disciple Yuan has passed the 99th stage! He's going to challenge the final floor now!" Bai Ling pointed at the tower and shouted in excitement despite the other people there already realizing this because they have been watching the tower this entire time.

"What kind of challenge do you think exists on the final floor?" Elder Shan asked out loud.

"Who knows, I have only reached the 83rd floor myself..." Xin Ming shrugged.

"The Sect Master also only reached the 92nd floor."

"Besides the Founder who stepped onto the 100th stage, I don't think anyone else knows what exists on the 100th floor, and the Founder didn't leave behind any notes about his experience in the tower except a single word— terrifying," said Long Yijun with a serious look on his face.

"Terrifying, huh? If even the Founder who is known for being fearless finds the 100th floor 'terrifying', just what could possibly exist on the 100th floor? I cannot wait until Disciple Yuan comes back outside." Elder Shan sighed.

Meanwhile, inside the tower, Yuan rested for 15 minutes in the resting area before walking up the stairs and entering the 100th floor.

And to his surprise, when Yuan stepped onto the 100th floor, he was greeted by a clear blue sky and a seemingly endless arena that stretched to the horizon, almost like he'd been teleported from inside the tower to another world that was made of a single stage.

Yuan looked down, and sure enough, the staircase he'd just walked on had suddenly disappeared.

«You have entered the 100th floor»

«A powerful presence emerges from the void»

Whoosh!

A massive black portal suddenly appeared a few miles away from Yuan, and a long figure emerged from the portal a few moments later.

This long and golden figure looked exactly like the Great One from the Tablet of Comprehension, but it paled in comparison in size and was no longer as enormous as the previous version that could block even entire stars with its mere body. However, that is not to say the Dragon wasn't huge, as it was taller than even the highest buildings in Yuan's world with the thickness of multiple trains combined together.

"Congratulations on reaching the 100th floor, human. You are the second person to have reached this far, and it has been over 100,000 years since the last visitor stepped onto this floor." The Great One glared at Yuan with its large golden eyes and spoke to him as though it was their first meeting.

"You don't remember me?" Yuan couldn't help but ask the Dragon.

"Remember you? Why would I remember someone I have never met before?" The Dragon was puzzled by Yuan's words. After all, even if it has been 100,000 years, it wouldn't forget someone when it has only met one other person beside him!

"So you're not the same 'Great One' as the one from the Tablet of Comprehension?" Yuan continued to ask due to his curiosity.

"Hmmm? The Tablet of Comprehension? Let me take a look at your body!"

The Great One suddenly flashed its eyes, and a golden light entered Yuan's body.

"You... You already have my Seal of Approval?" The Great One mumbled in a speechless voice, as it'd planned on giving Yuan the Seal of Approval if he'd passed the trial by beating the 100th floor! But now that Yuan already has the Seal of Approval, it has made this entire trial pointless!

"Yes, the other Great One gave it to me after I'd won a bet," Yuan said to the Great One.

"Hmmm..."

The Great One turned silent for a few moments before speaking, "Since you've already received the approval from the other 'me', I don't see a point in continuing this trial."

"Eh?! But why? I came all the way up here, too!" Yuan exclaimed in a dumbfounded voice. Did he really just climb 100 floors for nothing?

The Great One then continued, "I have taken a good look at your body just now, and as much as I hate to admit it, despite being a 1st level Spirit Master, I do not believe I have the capability to defeat you, who has two Soul Weapons and phoenix blood mixed in your blood, not to mention the two powerful presence I can feel hidden somewhere within your body."

"Although I am the same 'Great One' as the one you met in the Tablet of Comprehension, I am merely an illusion who has had its real powers limited to the level where it would make defeating this tower near impossible but also not truly impossible at the same time."

"Even if you say that, what are you going to do now if you're not going to fight me?" Yuan asked.

"Hmmm..."

The Great One began pondering again. After all, it cannot just let Yuan pass without giving him a trial.

A few moments later, the Great One spoke again, "How about this... In order to pass this floor, I will have you fight against 100,000 magical beasts

at the peak of the Spirit Warrior realm."

"100,000 magical beasts?!" Yuan's mouth dropped to the ground, as that amount was 1,000 more than what he'd had to fight on the 99th floor!

"While I can handle 100 magical beasts with ease, I definitely won't have the energy to defeat 100,000 magical beasts at once! This is definitely an impossible task!"

"Don't worry, I will make sure you have an ample amount of time to complete this challenge, as this is more of a test of endurance than your strength and talents, and you have already proved yourself in the other aspects."

"I shall bend the rules of this tower and give you unlimited time for this challenge because of the unexpected situation. Furthermore, I shall give you the ability to temporarily pause the challenge at will so that you can rest whenever you are exhausted or need a break. However, you are only allowed a total of 24 hours of rest time. Once you use up all 24 hours, you'll have to fight until you either defeat all 100,000 magical beasts or until you cannot go on and fail the challenge."

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Chapter 150 - 100 000 Magical Beasts

"24 hours of rest time and unlimited time to defeat 100,000 magical beasts..." Yuan pondered with a frown on his face. Since he can pause the challenge whenever he wants, it wouldn't affect his time in the real world unlike the Tablet of Comprehension. However, it will still take a very long time for him to kill 100,000 magical beasts, perhaps even days.

"What do I get for completing this challenge? Since you changed the original trial, I should get something in return, right?" Yuan asked the Great One.

"If you manage to pass this trial of mine, I shall grant you the key to the treasure room in the Dragon Temple. Since you have the Seal of Approval, I'm sure you intend on going to the Dragon Temple anyway in the future to try and obtain my Legacy. Inside the treasure room, you'll find a few things that I'd left behind before I ascended from this world and traveled to the upper heavens, and while there may not be much inside, each treasure will surely assist you in your cultivation path immensely."

"A dragon's treasures, huh?" Yuan nodded, as he cannot help but be curious about what a Dragon would consider as treasures.

"Then... I shall begin whenever you are ready."

Yuan took a few deep breaths before speaking in a resolute voice, "I am ready!"

"Very well..."

«The Great One's Challenge will begin shortly»

«0:10»

«0:9»

«0:8»

«0:7»

Yuan swallowed nervously as the seconds counted down.

Once the timer reached zero, Yuan suddenly felt the ground shaking a little bit.

"Huh?" Yuan's eyes widened with shock when he saw a black line suddenly appearing at the horizon, and this black line gradually grew larger and larger, and the earth shook harder and harder in response.

Very quickly, the black line transformed into a black sea, and Yuan could see a wave of magical beasts charging towards him like an army of ants at war.

'Holy... this is... this is much scarier than I'd thought!' Yuan cried inwardly, and his entire body trembled while all of his hair stood up like a porcupine when it's threatened.

'This is too much! They will definitely flatten me before I can even do anything!'

"Don't worry, Young Master. As long as you use the movement technique, it won't matter how many enemies there are—you'll be able to avoid them all flawlessly." Feng Yixiao's voice resounded in Yuan's head.

'Oh, right! I nearly forgot about that!' Yuan thought to himself.

Xiao Hua's voice resounded next, "Brother Yuan, don't forget about the Heavenly Domain. You can use it to suppress the magical beasts'

movements, which will make it easier for you to dodge their attacks and slay them!"

Yuan nodded, and he was no longer fearful of the sea of magical beasts swarming towards him.

'Hmmm... This kid... I can see why the other me gave him the Seal of Approval. You don't see this type of talent often even in the upper heavens...' The Great One thought to itself as it watched Yuan adjust to the atmosphere and emit a powerful aura that did not was not befitting of someone at the Spirit Warrior realm, as his aura was stronger than even most Cultivators who'd just reached Spirit Master!

"Brother Yuan, you can also use Heaven Splitting Sword Strike. Although it'll consume a lot of your spiritual energy, it'll be worth it since there are so many magical beasts bundled up together.

"Thank you for the advice, Xiao Hua!"

Yuan suddenly straightened his back and held the Empyrean Overlord like a knight before raising it high into the sky.

After charging the Empyrean Overlord with a portion of his spiritual energy, the Empyrean Overlord began emitting a bright golden light that was almost too blinding to look at.

"Hmm? What kind of technique is that? This aura... Could it be a Divine-rank martial technique?" The Great One was surprised to see someone as young as Yuan learn a Divine-rank technique and even reached such mastery with it.

Of course, if the Great One had known about what happened at the Tablet of Comprehension, it wouldn't care about a measly Divine-rank technique.

"Heaven Splitting Sword Strike!"

Yuan swung the Empyrean Overlord horizontally, sending a massive beam of light towards the army of magical beasts.

BOOOOOM!

The entire world shook as the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike disintegrated thousands of magical beasts in a single strike!

«You have slain 4,420 magical beast»

«95,580 remaining»

"Heavens!" The Great One exclaimed in a shocked voice when it saw the raw destructive power of the Yuan's Divine-rank technique. "Is that really a Divine-rank technique? To display such powers when he's only a Spirit Warrior, this must be one of the strongest Divine-rank techniques out there!"

However, despite killing over 4,000 magical beasts in a single strike, the black sea did not seem to have diminished even slightly, and they continued to charge at Yuan.

"Heaven Splitting Sword Strike!"

Yuan decided to use the technique again to lower the numbers again.

«You have slain 5,110 magical beast»

«90,470 remaining»

And again...

"Heaven Splitting Sword Strike!"

«You have slain 4,975 magical beast»

«85,495 remaining»

Yuan continued to use Heaven Splitting Sword Strike until a dozen times later when his spiritual energy lowered by half.

«49,321 remaining»

In just a few minutes, Yuan had managed to cut the number of monsters he needed to hunt in the trial by half.

'This human is a monster! Why does he have so much spiritual energy?! If it were any ordinary Spirit Warrior at his level, they would only be able to use such a powerful skill once or twice, yet this human managed to release over a dozen of them! It seems like I have underestimated him still! If I'd known about his power, I would've made him kill 1,000,000 magical beasts instead of 100,000 which is looking incredibly easy for him right now!' The Great One cried inwardly, but alas, even it could not stop the trial once it began.

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Chapter 151 - Unique Ability

After slaying over 50,000 magical beasts with the Emyrean Overlord, Yuan received an unexpected notification.

«Congratulations! Your Soul Weapon Emyrean Overlord has absorbed enough lifeforce and leveled up!»

«Your Emyrean Overlord has unlocked a new unique ability!»

«Emyrean Overlord»

«Level: 1»

«Rank: Soul Weapon»

«Growth Rate: Very Slow»

«Requirement: ???»

«Unique Ability: Amplify the power of all sword techniques by 100% when wielding this sword»

"100 percent?! Does this mean all of my techniques will double in power?! That's overpowered as heck!" Yuan exclaimed in a shocked voice, but he didn't have the time to think about it too much as the magical beasts continued to approach him.

Once the magical beasts were close enough, Yuan activated Heavenly Domain, creating a golden circle around him that extended for a dozen meters, slowing and suppressing everything within the circle to a certain extent.

"Another Divine-rank technique?! And it's even a restriction technique!" The Great One was dumbfounded once again after seeing Yuan use a second Divine-rank technique.

'I have looked at his bones, and he should be no older than 18 years old, yet he's already learned two Divine-rank techniques and can use them with such proficiency?! This human's comprehension ability is shockingly high!' The Great One thought to itself, unaware that Yuan had also learned its Dragon's Gaze from the Tablet of Comprehension.

Meanwhile, Yuan used the Flying Daggers technique with the Starry Abyss to slay the magical beasts that ignorantly entered the Heavenly Domain only to have their movements speed significantly decreased, even feeling as though they were suddenly carrying a large boulder behind their back.

Sha! Whoosh!

The magical beasts dropped like flies as the Starry Abyss flew around in a circle, instantly killing the magical beasts.

And because the Flying Daggers is only a Mortal-rank technique, it required very little spiritual energy to maintain, allowing Yuan to use it effortlessly and continuously.

'As expected of a Soul Weapon... it can rip apart magical beasts with ease despite using only a Mortal-rank technique, and by the looks of it, that Soul Weapon is still in its infancy period. I can only imagine how powerful it'll become once it grows up alongside a monster like this human...' The Great One said inwardly.

Whoosh!

Yuan swung the enormous sword in his grasp effortlessly at the magical beasts that the Starry Abyss could not reach in time, cutting down even magical beasts twice his size with a single swing.

"Blood Sword Strike!"

The Empyrean Overlord emitted a powerful aura that did not exist before.

BOOM!

«You have slain 23 magical beast»

«48,124 remaining»

However, despite the Heavenly Domain slowing down the monsters and Yuan killing the monsters at a rapid rate, there were simply too many magical beasts, and Yuan was surrounded by them a little later.

Though, it was not as though Yuan was in any danger, as the magical beasts were still restricted by the Heavenly Domain, so even if they wanted to attack Yuan, they would be too slow for him, who had a Divine-rank movement technique, allowing him to dodge the magical beasts despite being attacked by many of them at once.

When the Great One saw this, its eyes widened again, and it mumbled to itself, "That movement technique... Why does he know a movement technique meant for phoenixes? Does it have anything to do with the phoenix blood that's in his body? This human is full of surprises and mysteries... I'm sure the real 'me' in the upper heavens would love to meet someone like him."

Two hours of nonstop action later, Yuan shouted, "Great One! How do I pause this trial?! I need a break!"

"Just say 'pause trial'!" The Great One responded.

Yuan then shouted, "Pause trial!"

The moment Yuan spoke these two words, almost as though time itself had stopped, all of the magical beasts' movements came to a sudden halt, looking like they'd frozen in time.

«23:59:59»

«23:59:58»

«23:59:57»

"Don't forget, you only have 24 hours to rest." The Great One said to him afterward.

Yuan immediately sat down to cultivate and recover his exhausted spiritual energy.

Whoosh!

A few seconds after Yuan sat down and closed his eyes, the spiritual energy in the area could be seen rushing towards Yuan at a rapid speed, almost like he was a black hole sucking all of the spiritual energy around him.

"..."

The Great One was speechless after seeing this, and it mumbled, "A pure body that doesn't contain any impurities... Did he also consume the Translucent Dew of Flawlessness? What is someone like him doing in the Lower Heavens? One would have trouble finding the things he'd somehow managed to obtain even in the upper heavens!"

After resting for a few hours until half of his spiritual energy returned, Yuan stood up and asked the Great One, "How do I resume the trial?"

"Just say 'resume trial'."

Yuan nodded and prepared himself mentally before saying the word.

«Trial will resume in 3 seconds»

«2»

«1»

The moment the trial resumed, almost as though time began flowing again, the magical beasts began moving and continued to attack Yuan.

After fighting the monsters again for a few hours, Yuan paused the trial again to rest, and he repeated this process until it was time for him to log off for dinner.

"Pause trial!" Yuan then stood up and said to the Great One, "I'll be back after dinner."

When Yuan logged off and disappeared before its eyes, the Great One raised its eyebrows in a puzzled manner. However, it didn't say anything and merely closed its eyes and patiently waited for Yuan to return.

Once he'd returned to the real world and Yu Rou began her routine, Yuan recalled his experience for the day to Yu Rou while she cleaned his body and fed him soup. He spoke about playing the zither at the Dragon Pavilion, climbing the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate, and needing to defeat 100,000 monsters to pass the final trial.

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Chapter 152 - Perfect Concealmen

"The zither, huh?" Yu Rou mumbled after hearing about this instrument from Yuan, and she said a moment later, "People used to play those instruments in the ancient times if I remember correctly, but it's rarely played today."

"What? Why did people stop playing them? It's such a wonderful instrument that can invoke one's inner feelings with a single note!" Yuan asked in a surprised voice, as he couldn't understand why people suddenly stopped playing the zither.

"I'm not too sure either, but I can look it up online if you want." Yu Rou said to him.

"Okay."

"Give me a moment..."

Yu Rou pulled out her smartphone and did a quick search on the web.

"Zithers... Eh?" Yu Rou released a surprised voice.

"What is it?" Yuan raised his eyebrows and asked her with his interest piqued.

"Well... it says that the reason people stopped playing the zither was due to some curse... It doesn't make any sense," Yu Rou said.

"Curse?"

"Yes... They say those who play the zither are cursed with a fate worse than death..." Yu Rou said.

"What the heck? Do people actually believe in that crap? I can't believe it! To think they'd abandon such a wonderful instrument because of a mere 'curse'! If I'd known about this instrument before, I would definitely have made it my main instrument!" Yuan sighed loudly.

"Well, at least you get to play the instrument in the game, right?" Yu Rou said to him.

"I guess... But after learning about the zither, I cannot help but wonder what other instruments I can play in the game... While I am no longer a musician, playing the zither had flared some sort of flame in my body... I think..."

"Really? Now I have another thing to look forward to inside the game—seeing you play the instruments again! Maybe you can even become a famous musician in the game!" Yu Rou said.

"Famous musician, huh? I think I've had enough of that life," Yuan said with a bittersweet smile on his face.

"Oh... right..." Yu Rou realized that she'd opened an old wound for Yuan and quickly apologized, "I'm sorry, brother... I got too excited again..."

"Don't worry about it. Although I don't plan on becoming famous, I do want to play the instruments at times."

"But you're already famous, brother. You're 'Player Yuan', the number one player in the world right now!" Yu Rou said.

"Me? The number one player? On what basis?" Yuan asked since he cannot imagine how he'd be the number one player in the world when he hasn't really been doing much besides enjoy the game at his own leisure.

"On what basis, you say? By your progress, of course! Most players in the world are still learning Mortal-rank techniques, yet you've already learned your first Ancient-rank technique and even a couple of Divine-rank techniques! Your cultivation base is also vastly superior compared to the other players!"

"I see... But I don't really care if I'm the number one player or not— I just want to enjoy the game." Yuan said.

"I know you wouldn't care about something like this, but the other players care, especially the Legacy Family. That's why they're all looking for you," said Yu Rou.

"What will they do even if they find me?" Yuan asked.

"They'll probably ask you to join their family and share your secrets with them so that they can also progress as fast as you in the game."

"Secrets? There are no secrets, though. I just play the game normally." Yuan sighed.

"Nobody would believe that brother. I also wouldn't have believed it if I didn't know you."

"What a pain in the ass. I hope they'll never find me so that I can continue playing the game peacefully," Yuan said a moment later.

"I also hope the same, brother."

"By the way, Yu Rou, I left you at Phoenix City, right? Will you be okay by yourself?"

"Un. I will be fine. Not only do I still have the 100,000 gold that was given to me by Xiao Hua but I also have a friend from school who's also in Phoenix City, and I'd promised to play with her this weekend."

"A friend, huh? That's nice." Yuan said.

"I'll introduce her to you one day in the future, brother. She's a really sweet and elegant girl."

"Okay."

Sometime later, Yu Rou asked him, "You're going to play tonight, right? After all, you still have that trial..."

"Yes, I only have 24 hours of pause time. If I sleep now, I will probably fail the challenge."

"Okay, I'll leave you alone then. Good luck, brother."

Once Yu Rou left the room, Yuan returned to cultivation online and took a few minutes to prepare himself before he began slaying the monsters on the 100th floor until the morning came and he had to pause the trial again for breakfast.

Meanwhile, waiting outside the tower, Long Yijun and the other sect elders were puzzled, even slightly nervous.

"What's happening in the tower right now? It's been over a day since he'd entered the 100th floor yet he's still not done!" Elder Shan spoke out loud.

"Who knows what he's doing inside, but I have never seen anyone remain on a single floor for so long before." Long Yijun said.

And he continued, "Anyway, there's nothing we can do right now but until the 100th floor flashes either a red or golden light!"

Thus, they continued to wait for Yuan's result.

Inside the tower, Yuan continued to slay monsters for a few hours before pausing the trial and resting until half of his spiritual energy was restored so that he could continue fighting.

On the third day, a notification appeared before Yuan after he slew his 90,000th magical beasts.

«Congratulations! Your Soul Weapon Starry Abyss has absorbed enough lifeforce and leveled up!»

«The Starry Abyss has unlocked a new unique ability 'Perfect Concealment'!»

«Starry Abyss»

«Level: 1»

«Rank: Soul Weapon»

«Growth Rate: Very slow»

«Requirement: ???»

«Unique Ability: (Perfect Concealment) Use spiritual energy to turn the weapon invisible and conceal its presence flawlessly at will.»

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Chapter 153 - Clearing All 100 Floors

"Perfect concealment, huh? Let's try it."

Yuan then activated Perfect Concealment for the Starry Abyss, and just like the unique ability's description, the Starry Abyss suddenly became invisible with its presence and aura completely concealed.

However, in Yuan's eyes, the Starry Abyss was not completely invisible, as he could still sense his own spiritual energy around the Starry Abyss.

With that being said, for the magical beasts and even the Great One, it felt like the Starry Abyss had suddenly disappeared from this world, almost like it ceased to exist.

'I can no longer feel the presence of the second Soul Weapon... It must have the ability to conceal itself... This is an extremely powerful ability even for a Soul Weapon...' The Great One narrowed its eyes on Yuan, but alas, it could not sense the Starry Abyss no matter how much it tried.

'He can now kill even Spirit Masters without alerting them... What a terrifyingly powerful Soul Weapon... Where on earth did he obtain it?'

If the Great One knew that such a powerful Soul Weapon had once belonged to a family of mortals, it would definitely freak out.

Whoosh! Whoosh! Whoosh!

Now that the magical beasts could not even see or detect the Starry Abyss, they have become absolutely defenseless and powerless under its attacks, and they could only stand there and wait for their turn to be killed.

The speed at which Yuan killed the magical beasts suddenly doubled with the Starry Abyss's unique ability unlocked, and he killed the remaining 10,000 magical beasts in just a few more hours.

Meanwhile, Long Yijun and the sect elders waiting outside were almost shaking from anxiety.

"It's been four days since Disciple Yuan stepped onto the 100th floor, yet he's still inside... I wonder if something happened inside..." Long Yijun mumbled with a nervous frown on his face, as he cannot even begin to imagine losing someone as talented as Yuan in just a few days after he'd joined the sect!

"I hope it's nothing serious... Maybe it's like the Tablet of Comprehension, where he is given a week to finish." Elder Xuan sighed, trying to convince himself that nothing had happened to Yuan.

"Can one even die inside the tower?" Elder Shan suddenly asked. "The magical beasts inside are merely illusions. Although they can hurt you slightly from the impact, they cannot kill you— at least I have never heard of a disciple dying inside the tower before."

"The tower won't allow a disciple to die while inside. It will automatically stop the trial if it deems the disciple to be in a dangerous situation." Long Yijun said.

"But things could be different on the 100th floor..." Bai Ling said. "After all, none of us have been to the 100th floor before, so we cannot rule out that possibility."

The place immediately turned silent.

However, the very next moment, the tower suddenly began trembling.

"Eh? What's happening?!"

Before anyone there could even react, the 100th floor emitted a golden light, and a semi-transparent golden dragon suddenly escaped the tower and

appeared in the sky directly above the Dragon Essence Temple, shocking all of the disciples there and even people outside the sect!

This golden dragon flew a few circles around the Dragon Essence Temple before flying higher into the sky and disappearing from the peoples' view. However, a sound that resembled a dragon's roar could be heard a few moments later that echoed thousands of miles away, sending chills down the spine of everyone that heard it.

"Heavens! What on earth was that just now?!" Long Yijun cried out loud afterward, feeling his body rapidly heating up and his heart throbbing like war drums!

Meanwhile, disciples all around the Dragon Essence Temple could all see a golden tower standing majestically in the Outer Court, as the tower itself had suddenly changed appearance too.

"L-Look over there! That's the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower! The highest floor is emitting a golden light! Does this mean someone had managed to clear all 100 floors in the tower?!"

"Impossible! Who could've done such a thing?!"

Nearly every disciple in the sect began making their way to the Outer Court to see what was going on and witness for themselves the disciple who'd managed to achieve this incredible feat.

"Just like the Tablet of Comprehension and the silver tree—the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate has also become golden!" Elder Xuan exclaimed.

"H-He really did it! Disciple Yuan really defeated all 100 floors in the tower, becoming the first person in history to achieve such a grand feat!" Long Yijun stared at the tower that had all 100 floors emitting a golden light with a gawking look on his face.

"Sect Master, this is going to be troublesome. I have just received intel that many powerful figures from the other elite sects are approaching the

Dragon Essence Temple." Bai Ling suddenly said to him.

"Furthermore, the disciples from the Inner Court are also heading to this place."

"What a pain in the ass!" Long Yijun immediately retrieved his jade slip and activated it with his spiritual sense before speaking in a loud and domineering voice.

"This is the Sect Master speaking! Any disciple that approaches the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Tower will immediately have their disciple status stripped regardless of their status! This includes sect elders too! I repeat! Stay away from the tower!"

Long Yijun broadcasted his voice throughout the sect to every disciple like some sort of in-game announcement, and all of the disciples that wanted to approach the tower immediately halted their movements and no longer dared to continue forward.

"Dealing with the disciples in the sect isn't much of an issue, but for those outside the sect... We'll have to prepare for them." Elder Xuan said.

"It is what it is. I knew Disciple Yuan wouldn't be able to keep his talents hidden for long, but we'll still try our best to protect his identity until the Mystic Realm opens! Once that happens, the people managing the Mystic Realm will definitely be able to protect him!" Long Yijun said.

And he continued, "Elder Xuan, stay here until Disciple Yuan comes out. As for the rest of us, we are going to prepare for our guests!"

"Yes, Sect Master!"

Chapter 154 - Dragon Temple

Treasure Key

Inside the tower, Yuan was bombarded with notifications after completing the challenge by defeating 100,000 magical beasts.

«Congratulations! You have passed the 100th floor of 'Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate' in Dragon difficulty, clearing the trial!»

«Congratulations! You have completed the hidden quest 'Dragon Trial'!»

«You have obtained the title 'Dragon Warrior'»

«Congratulations, you have slain a total of 100,000 monsters»

«You have obtained the title 'Elite Monster Slayer'»

«Because of your title 'Elite Monster Slayer', all of your damage dealt to monsters will be increased by 50%. Monsters will feel more pain from your attacks as your damage to them increases»

«Your comprehension for Flying Daggers has reached a new level»

[Flying Daggers]

[Rank: Mortal]

[Mastery Level: 3]

[Description: Control your daggers with spiritual energy and send them flying through the battlefield, slaying your enemies from a distance! Qi

consumption will vary depending on how many Daggers you control at once and its speed.]

"So you've finally defeated all 100,000 magical beasts, huh... I knew it would've happened sooner or later, but I would've never even imagined that you'd clear the trial with such ease. Congratulations, you have become the first person to completely clear the Dragon Trial, and as promised, I shall bestow you the key for the treasure room now..."

The Great One opened its eyes widely, and a golden beam pierced Yuan's head the next moment.

«You have obtained 'Dragon Temple Treasure Key'»

A few seconds later, the Great One blinked, causing the beam to disappear.

"You now have the key to the treasure room," said the Great One. "Now you just need to enter the Dragon Temple and reach the treasure room, which will also be a challenge itself."

"Thank you," Yuan said.

"No, I should be thanking you... Thank you for coming here and entertaining me. I wonder how many more years I will have to wait until the next person reaches the 100th floor again— not that it really matters for me since I am merely an illusion, so the flow of time doesn't exist for me."

"One more thing... I'm sure that you already have been told about this by the other 'me', but I'd like to repeat it again. I want you to meet the real 'me' in the upper heavens. If you obtain the Legacy within the Dragon Temple and find the real 'me', you'll be given wealth and treasures that normal people cannot even begin to imagine."

Yuan nodded and said, "Don't worry, I'll definitely try to look for the real you once I reach the upper heavens."

The Great One then said, "Very well... The farewell, young genius..."

«You are now being teleported to the first floor»

A few seconds later, Yuan disappeared from the 100th floor and reappeared on the first floor again, feeling as though everything that'd just happened was merely a dream.

Once Yuan was gone, the Great One looked at the seemingly borderless sky and mumbled in a solemn voice, "He will definitely shake the entire cultivation world with his talents in the future if he hasn't already by now... However, the more talent he has, the more difficult his cultivation path will be, and I truly hope that he'll manage to survive until he meets the real me..."

"I shouldn't do this, but I really want you to meet the real me, so I shall make this an exception and give you an extra reward..."

The Great One suddenly began glowing and disintegrating into tiny lights like a bunch of scattering fireflies, flying towards the sky and disappearing into the distance.

Meanwhile, as Yuan approached the exit that was also the exit, the walls in the room began glowing, and tiny golden orbs of light emerged from the walls before flying towards him.

"W-What is happening?" Yuan watched as the golden orbs floated towards him before going inside his body.

«You have absorbed a massive amount of Qi»

«You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough»

«You have reached Sixth Level Spirit Warrior»

«+3,500 Stats»

«You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough»

«You have reached Seventh Level Spirit Warrior»

«+4,000 Stats»

«You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough»

«You have reached Eighth Level Spirit Warrior»

«+4,500 Stats»

«You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough»

«You have reached Ninth Level Spirit Warrior»

«+5,000 Stats»

«7,451,000,000/19,691,520,000 Qi»

"N-Ninth Level Spirit Warrior?!" Yuan was speechless after realizing that he'd suddenly gained 4 cultivation levels without doing anything.

Now even if he has the Pill of Concealment, he would still be at the second level of the Spirit Warrior realm, which is pretty attention-grabbing for a mere Outer Court disciple!

"I'll have to talk to Senior Xuan or one of the sect elders about this..." Yuan sighed as he opened the door and walked outside the tower.

"Huh?"

And to his surprise, almost like Elder Xuan had heard his sigh, Yuan could see Elder Xuan standing in front of the tower and staring at him with an intensive gaze.

"Senior Xuan—"

Yuan called out to him, but alas, before he could even finish speaking, Elder Xuan ran in front of him and grabbed his clothes before running away while dragging along like some kind of toy.

"I don't have time to explain right now! Just be quiet and come with me!" Elder Xuan said to Yuan in an urgent voice, dumbfounding him.

A few minutes later, they arrived at some unfamiliar building in the Inner Court and entered the building.

"W-What's going on, Senior Xuan? Why did we have to run like we're being chased by monsters?" Yuan asked him afterward.

"Why, you ask? It's all because of you!" Elder Xuan sighed out loud after locking the door.

"M-Me? Did I do something wrong?" Yuan asked him in a baffled voice, as he doesn't recall doing anything too crazy.

"Aiya... Even though we'd told you to remain lowkey until the Mystic Realm, you just had to go and show off your talents at the tower, huh?" Elder Xuan shook his head before taking a seat on the couch. "Sit down... I'll explain the situation to you right now."

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Chapter 155 - A Dangerous Situation

Once Yuan took a seat, Elder Xuan continued to speak, "Because of your performance at the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower, it has caught the attention of many, and experts from the other elite sects are currently approaching the Dragon Essence Sect even as we speak."

"Is that so..." Yuan mumbled in a calm voice, clearly still unable to grasp the situation at hand.

Elder Xuan shook his head and sighed, "I know you probably don't understand the dangerous situation you're in right now, so I'll explain it to you again."

"Do you remember what we told you about remaining lowkey until the Mystic Realm? If you're too talented, people will become jealous, and they will do everything in their power to destroy you so that you won't become a threat in the future. However, at the Mystic Realm, if you can attract the attention of the people managing the event, they will be able to protect you, and you might even be able to ascend to the next realm— Spirit Heavens!"

"This place we are currently in is called the Lower Heavens, and the next realm is called Spirit Heavens, where Cultivators above Spirit Grandmaster exists." Elder Xuan said.

"Anyway, that isn't important right now. What's important is your safety, Disciple Yuan. The other sects will definitely pressure us into revealing your identity, but you can rest assured that we give your name to them even if we have to fight."

"I'm sorry, Senior Xuan, I didn't think that I would cause such a commotion by participating in the trial, as I was only trying to experience the sect like a normal disciple," Yuan sighed afterward.

Elder Xuan immediately became speechless. Indeed, it wasn't Yuan's fault for going to the tower, as every disciple will eventually challenge it at least once. And nobody could've predicted that Yuan would clear all 100 floors, nor could they have predicted that the tower would react in such a manner when someone cleared the 100th floor, as it has never happened before.

"You don't need to blame yourself for this, Disciple Yuan. We want you to continue to experience life as a normal disciple even after this, but you should avoid things in the sect that has a ranking." Elder Xuan said.

"As for the other elite sects... they will only pressure us, and I doubt there will really be any fighting because our Dragon Essence Temple isn't weak, and the others know of this. They won't risk going to war with us over a single disciple, especially if they don't know your identity."

"If the sect is really in trouble because of me, I will do something about it myself," Yuan suddenly said.

"Huh? What do you mean by..." Elder Xuan's eyes suddenly widened as he'd just realized the aura coming from Yuan.

"Second level Spirit Warrior?! But you should have consumed the Pill of Concealment! Does this mean you're actually at the peak level now?! Ninth level Spirit Warrior?!" Elder Xuan exclaimed in a shocked voice, as he could've never imagined that Yuan would increase his cultivation level by four whole levels in a single day.

"Is this the result of clearing all 100 floors in the tower?" Elder Xuan couldn't help but ask.

Yuan nodded and said, "I think so."

"Can you tell me what you'd experienced in the tower? Especially on the 100th floor."

"Okay." Yuan then recalled his experience in the tower to Elder Xuan.

"Dragon difficulty? Only 15 minutes of rest for every 10 floors? 100,000 magical beasts at the peak Spirit Warrior realm?" Elder Xuan began sweating midway through Yuan's experience.

'Heavens! I don't think I would be able to defeat 100,000 peak-level Spirit Warrior magical beasts in such a short time even at my current level! Yet this young man who was only at the fifth level Spirit Warrior realm at the time was able to achieve such an incredible feat in four short days!' Elder Xuan looked at Yuan with deep admiration within his gaze.

"To think you'd experienced such a journey... It's no wonder the Founder called the 100th floor 'terrifying'." Elder Xuan sighed, completely unaware that the Founder had another challenge, which was much easier than the one Yuan had to endure because Yuan didn't mention the Great One changing the challenge for him.

"Anyway, I will let the Sect Master know about this once he's done with our guests. In the meantime, you can stay here until they leave." Elder Xuan said to him. "I don't want to risk anything."

"Okay. Once again, I apologize for the trouble..." Yuan said to him.

"There's no need for you to apologize, as this is simply how the cultivation world works." Elder Xuan said to him before leaving the building to group up with Long Yijun and the other sect elders so he can assist them in case anything happens.

Once Elder Xuan was gone, Feng Yixiao's voice resounded, "Don't worry, Young Master. If anyone dares to try and harm you, I will burn them alive until there's nothing left of them— not even their bones!"

"You don't need to worry about protecting Brother Yuan because Xiao Hua alone is enough to protect him." Xiao Hua said afterward.

"Won't it be problematic if a Spirit King like you suddenly starts killing Cultivators in the Lower Heavens? You might even invoke a Heavenly

Tribulation..." Feng Yixiao said. "I think it would be safer if I, a Spirit Grandmaster, protects the Young Master. After all, I am more than enough to protect him from most threats in the Lower Heavens."

"You don't have to worry about Xiao Hua. Xiao Hua has permission to be in the Lower Heavens, and killing a few Cultivators won't affect Xiao Hua," she responded in a calm voice.

"Why are we even competing with each other about who should protect the Young Master?" Feng Yixiao sighed.

Meanwhile, in the Sect Master's headquarters, Long Yijun sat in his chair while the other sect elders stood beside him like a group of bodyguards, and sitting before them was a group of Spirit Master experts, each of them wearing uniforms belonging to a different sect.

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Chapter 156 - Blessing In Disguise

"Welcome to the Dragon Essence Temple, esteemed guests. How may I help all of you today?" Long Yujin spoke with a friendly smile on his face, acting like he didn't know why they were there.

"You don't have to play dumb, Sect Master Long. You know exactly why we are here. Spare the ignorance and let us get straight to the point." One of the experts there suddenly said in an arrogant voice.

"..."

The friendly smile on Long Yijun's face immediately disappeared, and he responded in a cold voice, "Then I will be as straight as a sword— You lot coming here was a waste of time. I won't tell you anything, so you can all return to your sects now. Thank you."

"Don't be like that, Sect Master Long. We are only here because we are concerned about the phenomenon that happened in the Dragon Essence Temple not long ago," said a different individual.

"Concerned? About what? Why does whatever happens in the Dragon Essence Temple concern the Golden Hand Mountain or any of you for that matter?" Long Yijun said with a puzzled look on his face.

"Cut the crap, Sect Master Long. We didn't waste transportation treasures to come here just to go back empty-handed. Which disciple cleared all 100 floors in the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower? We all saw it on our way here— a golden tower with all 100 floors emitting a golden light!"

"And who told you to use those transportation treasures? I don't recall inviting any of you to the Dragon Essence Temple. Perhaps I am truly getting old..." Long Yijun cleaned his ears with his pinky.

"You damn old fart..."

The experts there gritted their teeth in irritation. They knew that it was going to be incredibly hard to get Long Yijun to open his mouth, especially when this is related to someone talented enough to make history, but they didn't expect it to be this difficult.

"Don't worry, you'll get to meet with this genius at the Mystic Realm in a month. Hahaha!" Long Yijun laughed out loud, and the sect elders standing beside him couldn't help but lose their composure and giggle like little kids in a serious classroom.

"Hmph! So what if he's slightly talented? That's not saying much since he's from this place! I doubt he'll be able to affect the Dragon Essence Temple's ranking in the Mystic Realm even if he can clear all 100 floors in the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate! In fact, I bet my disciples will be able to do the same!" One of the Sect Masters there suddenly exclaimed.

"Oh? Is that so? Are you willing to bet on that?" Long Yijun's eyes suddenly flickered with profoundness.

When the Sect Master saw Long Yijun's confident grin, he said, "Good! What do you want to bet on?!"

Long Yijun suddenly retrieved his spatial ring before taking out a beautiful golden sword from within, and he said afterward, "I will bet this Dragon Slaying Saber that none of your disciples will beat 100 floors."

"The Dragon Slaying Saber?! You're really going to bet that?!" The people there were greatly shocked by Long Yijun's offer, and they all swallowed nervously when they felt the overbearing aura emitting from the golden saber.

The Dragon Slaying Saber is a Divine-grade treasure that has been passed down from Sect Masters to Sect Masters in the Dragon Essence Temple, and it was unthinkable to them that Long Yijun would be bold enough to gamble such a precious treasure.

"Hahaha! Good! Since you're so confident, I shall also be confident!" The other Sect Master also retrieved his spatial ring before taking out a long green spear.

"That's the Divine Bamboo Spear! Sect Master Wang is also going to gamble his Divine-grade treasure!"

"Hey! Let me join! I also want my disciples to participate in this fun!" Another Sect Master suddenly said.

"What are you talking about, Sect Master Chang! How are we going to split the Dragon Slaying Saber if you join?"

"We can worry about the share later!" Sect Master Chang laughed.

Long Yijun laughed inwardly when he saw these Sect Masters acting so confident that they would win.

If clearing all 100 floors of the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower was so simple, he wouldn't dare to gamble with the Dragon Slaying Saber!

'Hahaha! These fucking idiots! If the Founder who was widely known as the number one genius in his era couldn't clear the tower, what makes these idiots think their disciple can?!' Long Yijun tried his best to not burst out laughing, as this was an incredible chance for him to earn two Divine-grade treasures at once!

"Since it's like this, I also want in!" Another person there suddenly stepped forward.

"Me too!"

"Fuck it! Since you're all going in, I'll also put my foot forward!"

In just a few minutes, all of the guests there have decided to send their disciple to the Dragon Essence Temple to challenge the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower.

Meanwhile, the sect elders from the Dragon Essence Temple looked at each other with disbelief in their gaze. Are they really going to earn this much treasure from this event? Perhaps this event is actually a blessing in disguise!

"What about it, Sect Master Long? Are you willing to let our disciples challenge the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower? If you win this bet, you'll get to obtain many Divine-grade treasures and other priceless artifacts! If you lose, you'll only be losing one Divine-grade treasure!"

"How do I know that you'll keep your words if I actually win? I want a blood oath from everyone participating in this!" Long Yijun suddenly exclaimed.

"What? You want our blood oath?" The other Sect Masters there looked at each other with a surprised expression on their face.

"If you can't do it then you can forget about participating in the event," Long Yijun spoke with a firm look on his face, causing the others to frown.

Chapter 157 - Blood Oath

When the Sect Masters there hesitated after hearing the words 'blood oath', Long Yijun coldly sneered, "It appears that you guys are all bark and no bite. Forget it! I never expected much from a bunch of spineless old frogs anyway!"

"Wait a damn second, Sect Master Long! Who are you calling spineless?! Since you are so confident, then watch as my disciples wipe that smug off your damn face! And I am well aware of what you're trying to do here! Don't think you can earn so many treasures so easily because as long as a single disciple from one of our sects manages to clear all 100 floors, it'll be our victory!" Sect Master Wang exclaimed.

Long Yijun nodded and said, "I don't mind. However, each sect can only bring three disciples to participate. After all, I don't have the time to let every disciple in your sect challenge the tower."

"Three disciples from each sect, huh? What do you guys think?" Sect Master Wang turned to look at the other Sect Masters.

"Hmph! You're being more generous than I'd anticipated, Sect Master Long. To think you'd be generous enough to give each of us three chances instead of just one—I will bow to that! However, you have just dug yourself an even deeper hole by giving us more chances! Since that's the case, I am willing to do a blood oath!"

"Me, too! Especially if only a single disciple is needed to clear all 100 floors!"

A few moments later, Long Yijun then said, "Very well! Then let me be the first to do my blood oath!"

Long Yijun suddenly stood up and used the Dragon Slaying Saber to cut a small opening in his thumb before speaking out loud while staring at the ceiling, "I, Long Yijun, under this blood oath and with Heaven as a witness, swear that if a single disciple from the sects that belong to these individuals before me manages to clear all 100 floors in the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower that I will forfeit my Dragon Slaying Saber!"

Long Yijun allowed a droplet of his blood to fall on the floor after his sentence ended, but surprisingly, the blood did not touch the floor and splatter as one would expect. Instead, the blood went right through the floor and disappeared somewhere.

"I have done my blood oath. If you dare to participate in this bet, swear a blood oath!" Long Yijun looked at the Sect Masters there and spoke in a domineering voice.

Sect Master Wang then stepped forward and swore, "I, Wang Mingqing, under this blood oath and with Heaven as a witness, swear that if none of the disciples from our sect can clear all 100 floors of the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower that I will forfeit this Divine Bamboo Spear in my hands!"

Sect Master Wang dropped his blood onto the floor, and it also disappeared into the floor like Long Yijun's blood.

Another Sect Master there stepped forward and began another blood oath, "I, Chang Hai, under this blood oath and with Heaven as a witness, swear that if none of the disciples from our sect can clear all 100 floors of the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower that I will forfeit this Blood Moon Cleaver!"

In just a few minutes, nearly every Sect Master there swore a blood oath.

"What are you guys waiting for? If you guys participate, we'll have more chances. Even if we have to share the Dragon Slaying Saber with all of us here, it will definitely be worth it! And there's simply no way that our disciples won't be able to clear such a childish trial!" Sect Master Wang

looked at the rest of the Sect Masters there that didn't want to participate and encouraged them.

However, these Sect Masters remained hesitant and suspicious about the whole situation. While none of them knew just how difficult the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower truly was, they could feel an ominous feeling coming from Long Yijun's nonchalant expression.

"Screw it! If you're too afraid to participate then don't! It just means that we'll have fewer people to share the wealth with afterward!" Sect Master Wang sneered.

"So a total of 4 sects will be participating in this bet, huh? Very well. Send your disciples here to challenge the tower before the end of the month, as I'd rather have this resolved before the Mystic Realm begins."

"Hmph! Don't worry, they'll definitely be here to take away your Dragon Slaying Saber!" Sect Master Wang said before turning around and leaving the place.

"Make sure you clean that Dragon Slaying Saber before you hand it to us, Sect Master Long! Hahaha!" Sect Master Chang laughed out loud as he walked away.

Sometime later, once the guests were long gone, Long Yijun returned to his seat and closed his eyes, seemingly deep in his thoughts.

The sect elders also took a seat in their own chairs.

A few moments later, everybody in the room burst out laughing collectively.

"Hahaha! These idiots really believe that their disciples can clear all 100 floors in the tower! These fucking idiots have no idea what they're going up against!" Bai Ling laughed out loud.

"We've really struck gold this time! To think we'd earn 4 Divine-grade treasures without needing to do a damn thing! This is practically free

money!" Xin Ming slapped his legs as he laughed hysterically.

Sometime later, Elder Shan spoke, "Although obtaining four Divine-grade treasure is a good thing, Sect Master Wang and the others definitely won't forfeit their treasure so easily. We can expect some hostility from them afterward."

"Elder Shan is right." Long Yijun nodded and continued, "They'll definitely do whatever they can to retrieve the treasures once they lose it so we'll have to prepare for that. Luckily for us, even though they're also elite sects, they aren't powers that we cannot handle, and I doubt they are going to immediately start a war with us over a Divine-grade treasure."

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Chapter 158 - Ninth Level Spirit Warrior

"What happened here? Where are the guests? Did they leave already?" Elder Xuan showed up at the scene a few minutes after the other Sect Masters left.

"Oh, Elder Xuan. You've missed it. The Dragon Essence Temple is about to be rich!" Bai Ling said to Elder Xuan with a broad smile on his face.

"Rich? How so?" Elder Xuan sat down before looking at Bai Ling with raised eyebrows.

"Well... This is what happened while you were away."

Bai Ling proceeded to explain to Elder Xuan what had transpired not long ago, about how the other Sect Masters have decided to send three disciples from each sect to challenge the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower, and if none of the disciples can clear 100 floors, they will each forfeit a Divine-grade treasure.

However, if a single disciple from any of the participating sects manages to clear 100 floors in the tower, the Dragon Essence Temple will forfeit the Dragon Slaying Saber.

"Heavens! You actually dared to use the Dragon Slaying Saber in a gamble, Sect Master?" Elder Xuan looked at Long Yijun with disbelief on his face.

The Dragon Slaying Saber is one of few precious treasures left behind by the Founder over 100,000 years ago before his disappearance, and it was unthinkable that Long Yijun would dare to risk it in a gamble.

"Though, unless they have someone even half as talented as Disciple Yuan, they will struggle to reach even the 99th floor. As for the 100th floor... hahaha! That's plain impossible unless they're as talented as Disciple Yuan!" Elder Xuan laughed.

Everybody in the room looked at Elder Xuan with wide eyes, as this is the first time they've seen him laugh in such a manner.

"Elder Xuan, did you perhaps ask Disciple Yuan about the 100th floor?" Elder Shan asked him.

"I certainly did! And it shocked me speechless when I heard about his experience in the tower!" Elder Xuan continued to laugh.

"Stop teasing us and share it with the rest of us already! What kind of challenge exists on the 100th floor?" Long Yijun said to him.

Elder Xuan nodded and cleared his throat before he recalled what Yuan said to him.

"Not only did Disciple Yuan have to ascend the tower at the highest difficulty set by the tower but he also had to slay magical beasts at the Spirit Warrior level on every single floor. Furthermore, he only had 10 minutes to clear each floor or he would automatically fail the challenge. To top it all off, he was only allowed 15 minutes of rest for every 10 floors!"

"Heavens! What kind of ridiculousness is that?! Even I didn't have such restrictions when I challenged the tower!" Long Yijun exclaimed in a terrified voice.

"Me neither. I had 15 minutes to rest after every floor, and I had unlimited time to clear each floor. 10 minutes per floor is simply impossible for me, especially after the 70th floor." Bai Ling said.

"Did you forget how fast Disciple Yuan cleared the tower? Not including the 100th floor, he did it in only a couple of hours! It took me nearly an entire week to reach the 85th floor!" Elder Shan sighed with admiration in her gaze.

"What about the 100th floor, Elder Xuan?" Xin Ming asked him.

"The 100th floor..." Elder Xuan took a deep breath before speaking in a slow but clear voice, "Disciple Yuan... He had to defeat a total of 100,000 peak level Spirit Warrior magical beasts..."

"One hundred— What?!"

Everybody in the room exclaimed in a terrified voice, sounding like they'd just witnessed their ancestor climbing out of their tomb.

"Not only did he have to defeat 100,000 magical beasts but he also only had 24 hours to rest. Once he uses up that 24 hours, he would no longer be able to rest. I don't know about you guys, but I wouldn't dare to claim that I can achieve such a feat at my current level even if you gave me a week of rest time, and I am a Spirit Master whilst Disciple Yuan is only a Spirit Warrior." Elder Xuan shrugged.

"A 5th level Spirit Warrior defeating 100,000 peak Spirit Warrior... I am beginning to believe that Disciple Yuan might belong to one of the Four Ancient Families." Bai Ling mumbled.

"Four Ancient Families? I doubt even they would have someone as freakish as Disciple Yuan! This young man is probably an Immortal in disguise!" Xin Ming spoke with a sweaty feeling.

"It's no wonder the Founder called it 'terrifying'. I wouldn't dare to step on the 100th floor even if I can now that I know what's waiting there." Elder Shan sighed.

"100,000 magical beasts... Hahaha... HAHAAHAHAHA! There's absolutely zero chance for those idiots now!" Long Yijun stood up and burst out laughing like some kind of maniac.

Sometime later, Elder Xuan spoke, "Oh, right. One more thing. You're going to have to give Disciple Yuan an even stronger concealment pill, Elder Shan."

"Eh? Why?" Elder Shan raised her slender eyebrows.

"Because he... he is now at the peak of the Spirit Warrior realm. I think clearing the tower had significantly improved his cultivation base." Elder Xuan said.

"P-Peak of the Spirit Warrior realm?!?!?" Elder Shan stood up from shock as did the other people there.

"B-But he's only like what? 18 years old? That's ridiculous! At this rate, he'll reach Spirit Master before the Mystic Realm even opens!" Xin Ming mumbled in a dazed voice.

"Luckily for us, the Mystic Realm doesn't limit participants by their cultivation base but their age instead." Long Yijun said. "Anyway, you guys can continue to prepare for the Mystic Realm. I shall stay here for a few more days just in case there are more guests later."

"Yes, Sect Master!"

Long Yijun then turned to look at Elder Xuan and said, "I'll leave Disciple Yuan in your hands."

Elder Xuan nodded and said with a smile on his face, "Don't worry, I'll take care of him as if he's my own grandson."

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Chapter 159 - Recruitment

"Sorry for making you wait, Disciple Yuan, but you are free to go now that the guests have left. And fortunately for all of us, nothing significant had occurred." Elder Xuan said to Yuan after returning to his side.

"Just remember, don't tell anybody that you were the one who cleared the tower today no matter what, and don't approach something that has a ranking. We cannot risk having your identity leaked before the Mystic Realm." Elder Xuan gave him another reminder.

Yuan nodded and said, "Don't worry, Senior Xuan, I won't do anything that might jeopardize my life as a disciple— oh..."

Yuan suddenly stopped speaking, and then he continued, "Disciple Min, my neighbor... she knows I was supposed to enter the tower after her."

"Disciple Min... Min Li from the Seven Legacy Families?" Elder Xuan immediately frowned.

"This is going to be troublesome and complicated..." he sighed a moment later.

"Why would it be complicated? I can speak with her and ask her to not tell anyone," Yuan said.

Elder Xuan shook his head and said, "The Seven Legacy Families is not as simple as you think. Even as a Grand Elder, I cannot approach her as I please. Furthermore, the Seven Legacy Families are always looking for talented individuals to join their family, even fighting with each other at times over individuals, and I cannot imagine that Min Li would intentionally hide your existence from her family since it will greatly improve her position within the family."

"Her family recruits talented people? Why would they do that? They're not a sect, right?" Yuan asked Elder Xuan.

"They may not be a sect, but that doesn't mean they have no reason to recruit talented individuals to further expand their own family's power and influence. In fact, large families like them tend to take recruiting talents more seriously than sects." Elder Xuan said.

"Anyway, don't let my words stop you. If you think you can convince Min Li to keep your identity a secret then by all means try. Even if she lets her family know, your identity should be safe for a while since I doubt the Min Family would be stupid enough to reveal your talents for their competitors until they can secure you."

"If the Min Family cannot persuade you to join their family then they might threaten to reveal your identity. Try to stall them until the Mystic Realm if they do approach you."

Yuan nodded. "I'll keep that in mind."

Sometime later, Elder Xuan left the scene, and Yuan returned back to his own living quarters.

However, as one would have expected, a familiar figure approached Yuan and blocked his path the moment she saw his figure from afar.

"Come with me. This is not a good place to speak," Min Li said to him before turning around and entering her own home.

Yuan nodded, "I also wanted to talk with you."

Yuan then followed Min Li into her home with an innocent and calm look on his face. If it were anyone else in his shoes right now, they'd be too nervous to enter Min Li's home alone.

Once they were inside, Min Li pointed at the couch and said, "Sit down. I'll go brew us some tea."

After Yuan sat down, Min Li went into the kitchen to brew some tea.

A couple of minutes later, she returned with a whole pot of tea and two pretty teacups.

"Here. Don't worry, I didn't poison or anything like that," Min Li said to him.

Yuan raised his eyebrows after hearing her words. Why would she say something like that? It was not as though he was expecting her to poison him in the first place.

A few moments later, the two of them began sipping on the tea without talking to each other for a few more minutes until Yuan placed down the teacup and sighed in a satisfied voice.

"Haaa... That was some great tea."

"Thank you, it's a family speciality." Min Li said after she placed her own teacup down.

"Anyway, what did you want to talk to me about?" Yuan asked her afterward.

"It will be a little long, so you can go first. You also wanted to say something to me, right?" Min Li said to him.

Yuan nodded and said, "I'd appreciate it if you can keep what happened today a secret. For various reasons, I cannot let people know that I was the one who cleared the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower today, as it might affect my life as a normal disciple in the sect."

Min Li looked at him with a dumbfounded look on her face. "A normal disciple? You? What kind of a joke is that? Would a 'normal' disciple destroy Training Puppets with Mortal-rank techniques? Would a 'normal' disciple clear all 100 floors in the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower? Who are you, really?"

"I don't know what else to tell you since I have already said that I don't belong to any powerful family..." Yuan said as he scratched his head, and he

continued, "I am just someone trying to enjoy life in this world while also trying to understand the cultivation world better."

Min Li turned silent after hearing his words, and after a long moment of silence, Min Li spoke with a serious look on her face, "If what you said just now is true— that you don't belong to any powerful family, then why don't you join my family?"

"..." Yuan widened his eyes when he heard Min Li's words, but he wasn't shocked because of her words. Instead, he was surprised at how Elder Xuan was right on the mark regarding Min Li and how she might try to recruit him to join her family.

"If you join the Min Family, you'll receive endless resources from the family to assist your cultivation, and if you receive enough support from the family, there's even a good chance that you will get to travel to the upper heavens and join the Min Family that's there."

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Chapter 160 - Seven Legacy Families

"If you manage to get accepted by the Min Family in the upper heavens, they will be able to supply you with even better cultivation resources, and your cultivation will soar at a speed that one cannot even begin to imagine. The Min Family is also a powerful family in the upper heavens, so you will have their backing."

Hearing Min Li's words, Yuan shook his head and said, "Although I am humbled that you'd invite someone like me to your family, I don't think I am ready to join any factions for real yet, as I don't want my freedom to be limited."

Min Li frowned at his words, and she spoke, "Then why did you join the Dragon Essence Temple? Your actions do not match your words, Disciple Yuan!"

"I only joined because they promised me that they wouldn't restrict my freedom and that I am allowed to leave the sect whenever I want. In other words, I am not required to give the sect my commitment. Of course, that is not to say I don't care about the sect."

"..."

Min Li turned silent afterward, and she pondered to herself.

'While it's not impossible for him to be free in the future, the Min Family will most likely restrict his movements for a while to ensure that he doesn't run away, especially if they learn about his unfathomable talents.'

Sometime later, Min Li opened her mouth again, "What do you want?"

"Huh?" Yuan raised his eyebrows in a puzzled manner.

"I'm asking you what it would take for you to join the Min Family! Do you want money? Do you want fame? If you're that kind of person, the Min Family can even provide you with as many beautiful women as you want!" Min Li said with a cold gaze.

"Uh..." Yuan was speechless. Why does Min Li seem so desperate trying to recruit him?

"Does it really matter if I join the Min Family or not? I am just a single individual, and there are plenty of talented individuals out there. It would be fine if you ignored one or two of them, right? Why do you want me to join your family so much?" Yuan decided to ask her.

"You have no idea what it means to be part of one of the Seven Legacy Families! Everything is a competition here! Your performance! Your achievements! Your contribution! Everything! I don't want to stay in the Lower Heavens forever, nor do I plan on staying here! And the only way I can leave this place is with my family's help!"

"However, just because I was born in the family doesn't mean I will naturally get their help! I must earn it! And I am currently nowhere near my goal whilst my siblings are way ahead of me! If I can recruit someone as talented as you into the Min Family, it will definitely help me achieve my goal! So please, join the Min Family! If you want, I will even become your woman! If you join the Min Family, they will definitely assign you someone within the family as your wife to keep you there, and I will volunteer to be your wife! No, I will even fight for that position if you want! If I somehow still lose, I will become your concubine instead!"

Yuan's jaw dropped after Min Li's unexpected outburst and offer. But alas, no matter how much he tried, he simply could not understand Min Li's feelings.

Yuan suddenly noticed the glistening tears in Min Li's eyes that were on the verge of falling and sliding off her face, which made him swallow nervously.

"I...Give me some time... I need to think about it..." Yuan spoke in an awkward voice a moment later.

Min Li wiped the tears from her eyes and nodded afterward.

"Don't worry, I won't reveal your identity, nor did I have the intention to from the start. After all, I cannot risk the other Legacy Families knowing about your existence before you join the Min Family!"

A few minutes later, Yuan left Min Li's house and returned to his own.

"Xiao Hua, Feng Feng, I have a question. Why would someone want to leave the Lower Heavens to go to the upper heavens? What's up there?" Yuan asked them in a pondering voice as he laid on the bed with a dazed look on his face.

"Most people— Cultivators yearn for the upper heavens because there are more opportunities there compared to this Mortal world. The Qi in that world is more abundant and dense, allowing Cultivators to cultivate many times faster. This also means the treasures that can be found in the upper heavens are more powerful and valuable, as they are being nurtured by higher quality Qi. It's like giving plants different qualities of fertilizers, and the better quality the fertilizers the better quality the plant will grow to be." Feng Yuxiang responded to his question.

"Brother Yuan, for us Cultivators, we always strive for constant growth. The Lower Heavens greatly limit our growth so it's only natural for Cultivators to want to travel to a place that is not as limiting." Xiao Hua spoke next.

"I see..." Yuan closed his eyes, seemingly trying to go to sleep.

However, Feng Yuxiang's voice resounded again.

"Young Master, if you're thinking about joining one of the Seven Legacy Families, I highly suggest you refrain from doing that."

"Eh? Why is that?" Yuan opened his eyes and asked.

"I don't know what the Seven Legacy Families look like in the Lower Heavens since I don't interact with them much, but in the upper heavens, they are all incredibly arrogant and self-centered people who will do anything to achieve their goals. I don't want someone like the Young Master to be affiliated with these kinds of people, as I am afraid that they might corrupt your mind and soul."

"As for what that little girl said... While I didn't detect any lies in her words, you can never be too cautious in the cultivation world."

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Chapter 161 - Stairway To Heaven

"I see... Thank you for telling me about this. I might have rushed my judgment if it were not for you, Feng Feng. If the Seven Legacy Families are truly such nasty people then I'd rather stay away from them," Yuan said afterward.

"As for Disciple Min... Maybe I can help her achieve her dreams without needing me to join her family."

"How does one even travel to the upper heavens, anyway? I know of the Stairway to Heaven, but are there any other methods one can use to travel to the upper heavens?" Yuan asked a moment later.

"Indeed, the Stairway to Heaven is only one of multiple methods, and it's even the second most difficult method, but despite that, it's the most used method by Cultivators since the other methods are somewhat unrealistic." Feng Yuxiang said, and she continued, "The first method, as most people know, would be to breakthrough the Spirit Grandmaster realm and become a Spirit Lord. Once that happens, you will be able to access the Stairway to Heaven and ascend the staircase without needing to clear the trials as you have already qualified to ascend with your cultivation."

"For our second method, as you know, would be to challenge the Stairway to Heaven and attempt to clear the trials to gain recognition and the qualifications to ascend. This is the most commonly used method simply because this allows Cultivators who have not reached the Spirit Lord realm to ascend to the upper heavens. Of course, it's not an easy thing to achieve, and only a couple of Cultivators will manage to pass the trials and ascend to the next realm every 100 years."

"As for the third and final method... while this is technically the easiest way to ascend, it's also the most unrealistic method, as it requires someone from the upper heavens to come down to the Lower Heavens and take you to the upper heavens. This is something only the Seven Legacy Families and the Four Ancient Families can achieve, as they have families in the upper heavens."

"However, even if they can do such a thing, it requires a tremendous amount of resources for someone in the upper heavens to come down to the Lower Heavens, hence why they only do that once in a blue moon when they have someone extremely talented."

"I see..." Yuan mumbled as he obtained a firm understanding regarding the upper heavens and the Stairway to Heaven.

Sometime later, Yuan said, "I am going to log off now. Too many things have happened today and I need some rest."

"See you later, Young Master."

"Goodbye, Brother Yuan."

Yuan logged off the next moment.

Once he returned to the real world, Yuan took a few deep breaths to calm his mind before he started cultivating until Yu Rou entered his room.

"Brother, you probably know about this already but apparently something amazing happened in Cultivation Online today!" Yu Rou said to him as she cleaned his body.

"Huh? What happened?" Yuan asked her.

"Many Players within the Eastern Continent heard a loud beastly roar that traveled hundreds of thousands of miles! Some even said it sounded like a dragon's roar! Maybe there's going to be a special event and the roar was some sort of sign!"

"R-Really? I didn't hear anything, though." Yuan mumbled.

Although Elder Xuan had spoken to him about his performance at the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower, Elder Xuan never mentioned the dragon escaping the tower, nor did he mention the loud roar that came from it.

"If it's true, you must try to participate in this event! Who knows what you might be able to get from it!" Yu Rou said to him.

"Okay," Yuan said.

"I will also keep my ears peeled for any information regarding this event. Once I learn something, I will immediately let you know!"

Sometime later, Yu Rou left his room and returned to her own room.

Yuan continued cultivating for the rest of the night afterward.

After his morning routine, Yuan dived back into the game and wondered to himself, "What should I do today?"

Yuan retrieved the guide book and began flipping the pages until he found something interesting.

"Oh, right. I have wondered what the Mission Hall looked like ever since they introduced it to the disciples. I should take a look at it now."

With this in mind, Yuan went outside.

However, he did not immediately leave and turned to look at Min Li's house, almost like he was expecting her to come out and follow him around.

But to his surprise, Min Li didn't show up.

"I guess I'll be alone today," Yuan casually shrugged before making his way to the Mission Hall.

As Yuan walked away from the area, Min Li peeked through her window curtains and watched Yuan's back disappear from her view.

Once Yuan was gone, Min Li squatted and covered her face with her hands in an embarrassed manner.

"What in heavens' name was I thinking yesterday?! Why did I offer myself to him?! He must now think I am some slut who'd offer her body to anyone that can help me achieve my goals! Aaaaah! I shouldn't have spoken without thinking about it!" Min Li cried out loud with her face flushed with redness, feeling like digging a hole and jumping into it.

"I want to follow him and see where he's going today, but I don't have enough courage to stand before him and act like nothing happened yesterday! Ahhhhh! Damn it! I should've waited a bit longer before inviting him to join the Min Family!"

Sometime later, Yuan arrived at the Mission Hall. It was a large two-story building that took up an entire block with disciples constantly entering and leaving the place, being one of the most active areas that Yuan has experienced in the sect thus far.

But that's to be expected since this place is where most disciples go to earn their contribution points, which is mandatory if they want anything from the sect.

Chapter 162 - Visiting The Mission Hall

After taking a moment to admire the outside view of the Mission Hall, Yuan entered the building through the wide entrance that could fit even 10 adults if they stood side-by-side.

"Wow..."

Yuan was immediately baffled by the atmosphere in the Mission Hall, as it looked like some sort of unorganized office with papers pinned all over the walls. In fact, one wouldn't be able to avoid seeing these papers no matter which direction they looked.

After entering the building, Yuan approached the pinned papers on the walls and began reading a couple of them.

"The Chun Family is looking for someone to escort their carriage from Huang City to Jin City. 100 gold as a reward. Fourth level Spirit Apprentice and above preferred. 5 Contribution Points."

"The Ming Family is looking for Cultivators to clear out the magical beasts that have been roaming dangerously close to their city. 1 gold coin for every magical beast slain. Third level Spirit Apprentice and above preferred. 1 Contribution Points for every 30 magical beasts slain."

"Sect Elder Bai from the Golden Lance Palace is looking for perfectly extracted 'Poison Sacs' from Demonic Spiders. 1,000,000 gold coins each. No cultivation requirements. 5 Contribution Points for each exchange."

"The Jie Family is looking for someone to manage their household while they go on a business trip for 7 days. 15 gold coins. No cultivation requirements. No Contribution Points."

"The Lord of Sparrow City is looking for someone to slay the 'Red Demon' that is running rampant around their territory. 10,000,000 gold coins. Fifth level Spirit Warrior or above preferred. 50 Contribution Points."

After spending a couple of minutes looking through a few missions on the walls, Yuan noticed one thing. The majority of these requests were related to slaying monsters or acting as a guard for some families with some missions requiring only materials, and very few of them were not related to Cultivators. As for those missions that did not require any cultivation, the majority of them did not give Contribution Points, so one can assume that they were meant for disciples who only wanted to fulfill their duty as a disciple and nothing else.

"Oh? Those papers are colored differently." Yuan noticed the yellow papers gathered not too far away from him and approached them.

"Inner Court Disciple Huang is looking for a sparring partner. 1 Contribution Points for every hour of sparring. First level to second level Spirit Warrior. Meet at Lonely Peak in three days at 3 PM after the posting date."

"Outer Court Disciple Gong is looking for someone to clean his clothes. 1 Contribution Points for every 50 batches of clothes. No cultivation required. Meet at building #2,910 in the Outer Court."

"Core Disciple Xing is looking for someone to give her massages once a week. 5 Contribution Points every session. No cultivation level. Female disciples only. Meet at building #55 in the Inner Court. An interview is required before being hired."

Yuan read these yellow-colored missions with his interest piqued, 'So even disciples are allowed to create their own request to put in the Mission Hall, huh? However, won't disciples be able to abuse this by coordinating with

each other so they can complete each other's mission and avoid doing real missions to fulfill their disciple duties?'

However, after looking around some more, Yuan noticed a large paper that said, "Requests commissioned by fellow disciples will not count towards your disciple duties!"

"Oh... I guess this solves it..." Yuan mumbled to himself.

Yuan then looked at the Contribution Points he had left.

'781... I should be fine for a while even if I don't do any missions. However, I do want to experience what it would be like to accept a mission. I don't want to travel outside the sect so I'll pick one created by a fellow disciple.'

With that in mind, Yuan began looking through most of the missions that were requested by disciples in the Dragon Essence Temple.

After looking for a few minutes, Yuan's gaze suddenly stopped at a particular mission, mostly because it mentioned a word that immediately caught his attention.

"Core Disciple Fei is looking for an Outer Court disciple surnamed 'Yuan' who is experienced with the zither. 50 Contribution Points to anyone that can provide accurate information that leads her to him."

'50 Contribution Points just to find me?! That's the same level of reward as the other mission that required one to fight some 'Red Demon'! Fairy Fei? Isn't this the disciple who played the zither at the Dragon Pavilion? Why is she looking for me?' Yuan mumbled to himself.

After pondering for some more, Yuan turned to look at the disciple standing beside him and gently tapped the disciple's shoulder.

"Excuse me, this is my first time in the Mission Hall. How do I accept a mission?" Yuan asked the disciple in a friendly voice.

"Oh... You can just tear the request off the wall and take it to the counter over there—" The disciple pointed to the desks near the entrance.

"Thank you very much," Yuan said to the disciple before taking Fairy Fei's request off the wall and walking towards the desk.

"I'd like to accept this mission from Core Disciple Fei." Yuan showed the request to the sect elder behind the desk.

"Core Disciple Fei?" The sect elder looked at the request with wide eyes.

"50 Contribution Points for a request of this level?" The sect elder was speechless, as this is possibly the most overpaid request he has ever seen before.

However, since this is Core Disciple Fei who is known for being rich with Contribution Points because of her contributions at the Dragon Pavilion, it wasn't too shocking that she'd spend so luxuriously for something so simple.

"What's your name?" The sect elder asked.

"Disciple Yuan," Yuan responded.

"Eh?" The sect elder looked at Yuan in the face with a gawking expression. What on earth was going on here? Is he the same person Disciple Fei was looking for? Why is he turning himself in?

'Ah, whatever. It's not my job to care about such matters.' The sect elder thought to himself and decided to ignore their situation.

Chapter 163 - Disciple Fei

"Here, take this, you'll need it to enter the Inner Court since you're still an Outer Court disciple. You can also locate Core Disciple Fei's living quarters with this." The sect elder handed Yuan a token after writing a few things down in his book.

"Thank you," Yuan accepted the token and turned to walk out of the Mission Hall shortly after.

After leaving the Mission Hall, Yuan followed the map in the token to Fairy Fei's living quarters.

An hour later, Yuan reached the end of the Outer Court that was also a border between the Outer Court and Inner Court.

"I would like to enter the Inner Court for a mission," Yuan handed the token to one of the sect elders stationed there.

"Hmm... let me see..."

The sect elder looked at the token and nodded, "I see... Okay, here's your permission slip. Make sure you don't lose it, and you are only allowed to stay within the Inner Court for 4 hours. Once your time is up, the permission slip will destroy itself. If you're caught inside the Inner Court without a permission slip, you'll be punished, so make sure you keep that in mind. Of course, you can extend the time by coming back here. However, I am only allowed to extend your time if you still haven't completed your mission."

"I understand," Yuan nodded.

After entering the Inner Court, Yuan continued to follow the path towards Fairy Fei's house, and as an Outer Court disciple inside the Inner Court, Yuan naturally attracted the gazes of the Inner Court disciples there.

Although he'd encountered a few Outer Court disciples on his way to Fairy Fei's house, it was only like one out of one thousand disciples that were Outer Court disciples there.

Many minutes later, he arrived in the area where Core Disciples live.

"Let's see... building #7..." Yuan walked around the spacious area and looked at each building individually.

After walking for about ten minutes, Yuan suddenly stopped walking when a distinct sound entered his ears.

"This sound... Someone's playing the zither. It's most likely Disciple Fei."

Yuan proceeded to follow the sound of the zither and arrived in front of this large building a few minutes later.

Right as Yuan stepped onto the doorstep, the zither music stopped, and the sound of people clapping followed immediately afterward.

"That was amazing, Senior Sister Fei! It's only been a week since I last heard you play the zither and you have already improved to the degree where I almost couldn't recognize your music!"

"Me too! If I didn't watch you play, I would've thought it was someone else!"

"Congratulations, Senior Sister! Your Zither Arts has improved to another level yet again! At this rate, it won't be long before you are able to use 'that' Zither Technique!"

Yuan could hear a couple of unique voices coming from the other side of the house, and they were all female voices.

Knock *Knock*

Yuan knocked on the door a few moments after the zither music stopped.

"Are we missing someone today? I thought we weren't expecting any more guests today."

"I don't think anyone else is supposed to be here."

"I'll go see who it is..."

A few moments later, a pretty Inner Court disciple opened the door and appeared before Yuan.

"An Outer Court disciple? Do you know whose door you're knocking? What do you want?" The Inner Court disciple asked Yuan with an irritated expression on her face, mostly because she saw Yuan as a nuisance who was disturbing their time with Fairy Fei.

"I'm here to see Disciple Fei," Yuan said to her.

"D-Disciple Fei?" The Inner Court disciple looked at Yuan with a gawking expression on her face, almost like she was in disbelief.

"Y-You're just a mere Outer Court disciple! How dare you address a Core Disciple so casually? Do you think you are friends with her or something?! Get out of here before I shove my foot up your butt!"

Yuan was speechless. Why did the Inner Court disciple suddenly become so aggressive?

"Calm down, Junior Sister Feng. A young lady shouldn't speak so vulgarly, especially not when you're in Senior Sister Fei's house. What's with the commotion, anyway?" Another Inner Court disciple appeared before them.

"Hmph! Blame this disrespectful Outer Court disciple!" Disciple Feng said while pointing at Yuan's innocent-looking face.

"Hm?" The second Inner Court disciple looked at Yuan's handsome face for a moment before speaking, "What did you do to anger my Junior Sister so much?"

"I... I don't know." Yuan shrugged his shoulders in an innocent manner.

"Y-You little thing!" Disciple Feng immediately fumed again. "How dare you say that you don't know! You addressed Senior Sister Fei as 'Disciple Fei' like you're her friend! That is unacceptable for an Outer Court disciple!"

Yuan looked at her with wide eyes, "Really? What's wrong with calling a fellow disciple 'disciple'?"

"Are you seeing this, Senior Sister Ying? This guy has no awareness at all!"

The other Inner Court disciple shook her head with a bittersweet smile on her face, and she said, "You're here for Senior Sister Fei, right? Since you were able to come here, it must have been approved by a sect elder. Why do you need to see her?"

Yuan then retrieved the mission paper and showed it to them, "I'm here for this."

"Let me see that..." Disciple Ying took the paper from his hands to look at it closely.

"Did you know about this? I didn't know that Senior Sister Fei had created a request in the Mission Hall. And who's this 'Yuan'?"

"Uhh... That would be—"

Before Yuan could even finish his sentence, another voice interrupted him, "What's going on out here? Who's outside disturbing my performance?"

A few moments later, Fairy Fei appeared before them.

"H-Hello..." Yuan said to her with a stiff smile on his face.

"Y-You are!" Fairy Fei's eyes widened with shock after seeing Yuan's face, and she staggered backward until she bumped into a wall.

Chapter 164 - Do You Know This Outer Court Disciple?

"Y-You are! What are you doing here?!" Fairy Fei pointed at Yuan with trembling fingers and a shocked look on her face, dumbfounding the Inner Court disciples there.

"S-Senior Sister Fei? Are you okay? Do you know this Outer Court disciple?" Disciple Ying decided to ask her.

"I... I..." Fairy Fei was speechless. How is she supposed to answer such a question? Tell them that she was defeated by this Outer Court disciple in her own field of expertise?

"T-This Outer Court disciple... is my assistant!" Fairy Fei spurted out without thinking.

"Your assistant?" They all looked at her with wide eyes.

'Since when did Senior Sister Fei need an assistant?' Disciple Feng wondered to herself.

'Since when did I become her assistant?' Yuan asked himself with his eyebrows raised in a funny manner.

Fairy Fei immediately panicked, and she corrected herself after clearing her throat, "I-I meant to say that he's my student! That's right! I am currently teaching him how to play the zither!"

"What?! You accepted this Outer Court disciple as your student?!" Disciple Feng exclaimed in a baffled voice. Why did Fairy Fei accept an Outer Court

disciple as her student— a man at that— when she, an Inner Court disciple and her friend, has been asking Fairy Fei to teach her the zither?

"He may not seem like it but he has great talent, and I believe that he will eventually surpass me one day..." Fairy Fei spoke whilst trying her best to not choke on her own words due to how ridiculous it sounded for her.

Fairy Fei looked at Yuan with her heart beating like crazy, but when she noticed that Yuan wasn't saying anything, much less call out her bullshit even a few moments later, she sighed in relief inwardly.

"I-If you think I have made a mistake by accepting him as my student, why don't we let him play the zither so you can determine whether he's truly worthy or not?" Fairy Fei suddenly suggested.

The disciples there turned to look at Yuan with suspicious gazes.

'Can he really play the zither?' They wondered inwardly because usually only women would pick up the zither.

"What do you think, Disciple Yuan? Can you play the zither for us? Just one song will be enough..." Fairy Fei looked at Yuan with a stiff smile on her face.

"I don't mind, since I would also like to play the zither again..." Yuan nodded his head after pondering for a moment.

"Great! Come inside!" Fairy Fei's face beamed with delight after seeing Yuan's approval.

"Uhh..."

Disciple Ying and Disciple Feng looked at Fairy Fei with a dumbfounded look on their faces, as Fairy Fei looked to be the most excited one for some reason.

Sometime later, Yuan entered Fairy Fei's house and closed the door behind him before following Fairy Fei and the Inner Court disciples to the yard behind the house, where two more Inner Court disciples were waiting.

"Welcome back, Senior Sister Fei. What took you so long? My ears have gone cold from waiting for your next song!" One of the disciples there said.

"Hmm? Who's that? Eh? An Outer Court disciple? And a man at that? Why is he here?" The other disciple asked after seeing Yuan's figure.

"Junior Sister Zhao, Junior Sister Gu, this is Disciple Yuan, an Outer Court disciple and also my student," Fairy Fei introduced Yuan to the two girls and vice versa.

"S-Student? Senior Sister Fei's student? How come this is my first time hearing about this?" Disciple Gu mumbled, as she has known Disciple Fei for many years now.

"Because it was only recently that I'd accepted him as my student." Disciple Fei said.

"Anyway, Disciple Yuan is going to play one song for us as an introduction."

"You can use that zither over there." Disciple Fei pointed at the beautiful zither sitting on the table a few meters away.

Yuan nodded and sat down behind the zither a moment later.

'Senior Sister Fei is actually letting a man touch her zither? This is... Shocking would be an understatement...' The disciples there looked at Yuan sitting behind the zither with dumbfounded expressions on their pretty faces.

They all knew how much Disciple Fei treasured her precious zither— so much so that even they had never touched her zither before.

Meanwhile, Yuan stared at the elegant azure-colored zither before him with a calm gaze.

After a moment of silence, Yuan lifted his head to look at Disciple Fei and asked her, "Which song should I play?"

"Do you remember the first song you played on that day? You can play that one."

Yuan nodded and took a deep breath before lifting his arms in a slow but smooth manner.

The next moment— Ting~!

A string on the zither trembled, creating a clean and crisp sound that immediately pulled the heartstrings of the disciples sitting not far away from it.

Another beautiful zither note resounded in the area not even half a second later.

'W-What is this feeling?' They all wondered to themselves the indescribable feeling in their heart, completely unaware that they'd just been bewitched by Yuan's zither skills.

Meanwhile, Disciple Fei had long closed her eyes to fully indulge herself in Yuan's zither music.

Time passed very quickly, and before the disciples were aware, Yuan played the last note on the zither.

"What do you think?" Yuan asked the disciples, snapping them out of their daze.

"I... Uhh..."

The disciples were speechless, and they turned to look at Disciple Fei with perplexed looks on their faces. While it was obvious that Yuan's performance was superior when compared to Disciple Fei's performance that occurred before Yuan's appearance, they didn't dare to say it to her face, as that might anger her and get them banned from listening to her performances in the future.

"C-Can you play another song? I don't think I can tell your skills just from a single song..." Disciple Zhao suddenly said.

When the other disciples heard Disciple Zhao's words, they quickly agreed with her, "Yeah! Play another song for us so we can judge properly!"

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Chapter 165 - In Need Of A Partner

When the female disciples began demanding a second song, Yuan turned to look at Disciple Fei, who quickly nodded her head, giving him the approval to continue using her zither.

Thus, Yuan placed his fingers on the zither strings once again and began playing another song.

The atmosphere immediately changed again, and Yuan's zither music echoed throughout the area, allowing disciples far away from their location to enjoy the music as well.

"Wow! This must be Fairy Fei's zither performance! I think she has improved yet again!"

"As expected of a genius, her talents with the zither are off the charts!"

"What beautiful music... I can listen to this all day if it was an option..."

Yuan finished his second song a few minutes later, and the world turned quiet again, even feeling a little bit lonely without the music.

"A-Again! Play another song, Disciple Yuan!" One of the Inner Court disciples said with a slightly bashful look on her face.

"Yeah! Two songs are not enough! You need to play at least a dozen songs!" Another one said.

"A dozen songs...?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"You can play until you are satisfied," Disciple Fei suddenly said to him.

Yuan nodded, and he began playing the zither again shortly after.

Meanwhile, the Inner Court disciples and Disciple Fei closed their eyes and fully indulged themselves in the music, feeling their minds entering an indescribable state that allowed them to think with more clarity, almost like there was some sort of special effects coming from Yuan's zither play.

An hour later, Yuan suddenly stopped playing the zither, as he'd run out of songs to play.

"Eh? Why did you stop? I was so close to entering a state of enlightenment! At least that's what it felt like!"

"Don't stop! Play some more!"

The Inner Court disciples immediately began complaining.

However, Yuan shook his head and said, "That's all the songs I know."

"Just repeat the songs then!" One of them quickly responded.

"Okay, calm down, Junior Sisters. Disciple Yuan has already showcased his abilities enough. Let's give him a break." Disciple Fei said, and she continued, "Furthermore, this gathering was supposed to end over an hour ago. Come back next month, perhaps Disciple Yuan will be here again."

"If you say so, Senior Sister Fei..."

Although the Inner Court disciples were reluctant to leave, they had no choice.

"I'm sorry for being rude to you at the beginning, Disciple Yuan." Disciple Feng said to him with an apologetic expression on her face before leaving the place.

"I would also like to apologize for doubting your abilities, Disciple Yuan. Thank you for today's performance." Disciple Ying said to him with a

friendly smile on her face.

"If you ever need anything, you can find me at Building #921," said Disciple Gu.

"See you next time, Disciple Yuan. Make sure you're here next month, too!" Disciple Zhao said to him.

Once all of the Inner Court disciples left the place, leaving Yuan and Disciple Fei alone, Disciple Fei immediately lowered her head slightly and spoke in an apologetic voice, "I am really sorry for calling you my student and pressuring you to play the zither again!"

Yuan shook his head and spoke in a calm voice, "There's no need to apologize. I don't mind it, and I also wanted to play the zither."

Disciple Fei nodded, and then she said a moment later, "By the way, what are you doing here? Why were you knocking on my house?"

"Oh, right... I nearly forgot..." Yuan showed Disciple Fei the mission that she'd created.

"Ah... that..." Disciple Fei immediately blushed, looking like someone who was caught doing something embarrassing.

"I wanted to look for you regarding something coming up, but I didn't know where you lived or who you were even after asking many sect elders, so I could only resort to such a method..." Disciple Fei said, and then she continued, "And since you showed up yourself, I guess it technically means that you have completed my request, so I'll give you the 50 contribution points now. Give me your identification token."

Yuan nodded and handed Disciple Fei his identification token.

"Hm? This is a bronze identification slip. What happened to your gold one?" Disciple Fei asked him when she noticed this.

"You mean this one? I only use it when I need contribution points since the bronze one has none," Yuan explained.

"Y-You have two identification tokens?" Disciple Fei looked at him with wide eyes.

Why would they give him two identification tokens? It was almost as though the sect was trying to hide Yuan's real identity.

However, Disciple Fei decided to not think too deeply about this for now and transferred the contribution points to him.

"I gave you 60 contribution points instead of 50 because of your performance just now," Disciple Fei said to him after returning the identification token to him.

"Thank you," Yuan said afterward.

"By the way, you said that you were looking for me? Why?" Yuan asked sometime later.

"About that..." Disciple Fei suddenly began acting hesitant.

A few moments of silence later, she spoke, "Well... I am in need of a partner..."

"Partner?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"What kind of partner?" He asked her with an innocent face.

One would normally think of 'lovers' when they hear the word 'partner' from a female, but Yuan was too innocent to think of such things.

"There will be a large zither competition next week, and I need a partner in order to even participate. I have been looking for someone who can play the zither even half as decent as I can, but there's no such person in the Dragon Essence Temple. However, you... you can definitely do it! Please! I will pay you as many contribution points as you want if we can participate in this competition!" Disciple Fei said to him in a slightly desperate voice.

"Zither competition, huh? What's so special about this competition anyway?" Yuan asked, his interest piqued.

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Chapter 166 - Zither Competition

Hearing Yuan's question, Disciple Fei said, "This zither competition is one of the largest competitions in the continent that occurs only once every three years, and as you may have expected, it gathers the best musicians from around the world. Despite my abilities that are widely praised by the entire sect, I'd only placed 7th in the last competition out of thousands of participants."

"Seventh out of thousands? That's already very good..." Yuan said with slightly wide eyes.

"Seventh place may be good but it isn't good enough! I want at least 3rd place, as that's when you get the real rewards!" Disciple Fei said.

"What kind of rewards?" Yuan asked, his interest piqued.

"For the last competition, third place got some Earth-rank Zither Art as a reward. The second place received a Heaven-rank Zither Art, and the first place received a Heaven-grade treasure that is also a zither."

"Zither Art? What are those?" Yuan asked.

"They are... Here, let me show you instead. It'll be much quicker that way."

Disciple Fei then sat behind her zither and took a deep breath before pulling one of its strings.

Ting!

A sharp and aggressive music note that Yuan wasn't familiar with resounded and a somewhat transparent arc that resembled Yu Rou's Wind Blade technique flew from the zither before hitting a teacup on the table a

few meters away and cleanly slicing it in half, almost like someone had slashed it with a thin sword or a sharp weapon.

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"What you've witnessed just now is Zither Art without any techniques. By infusing some spiritual energy into your fingers and releasing it with the zither, you can turn the zither into a deadly long-range weapon." Disciple Fei said to him.

"Turning instruments into weapons?" Yuan looked at her with a gawking expression on his face, as he would've never imagined that such a thing could be possible.

Disciple Fei then continued, "As for this year's competition... Because they will be receiving support from the Heaven and Earth Palace, the rewards have become much more valuable and desirable. Third place will receive an Earth-rank Zither Art technique and an Earth-grade treasure. The second place will receive a Heaven-rank Zither Art technique and a Heaven-grade treasure. As for the first place, shockingly, you will receive a Divine-rank Zither Art technique and a Heaven-grade treasure! Do you have any idea how valuable Divine-rank techniques are?!"

"A Divine-rank Zither Art technique..." Yuan mumbled in a low voice.

However, despite the temptation of a Divine-rank technique, Yuan was more interested in the Heaven-grade treasure, as he wanted a zither of his own.

"And you want me to participate in this competition with you, right?" Yuan asked her a moment later.

"That's right! With your zither skills, we'll have a great chance of reaching the top 3! If we reach the top three, we'll share the Earth-rank Zither Art and you can keep the zither since I already have one! My current Zither Art is only Mortal-rank after all! What do you think? I'll even pay you contribution points for your participation!" Disciple Fei looked at him with a pleading gaze.

After pondering for a moment, Yuan nodded his head and said, "Okay, I'll participate in this competition with you. Just let me know when."

"Thank you very much! I'll let my Master know later!" Disciple Fei was so excited that she unconsciously grabbed Yuan's hands and shook them vigorously.

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"By the way, now that we're going to be partners in this big competition, we'll need to practice and hone our skills before the competition. Since you cannot enter the Inner Court easily as an Outer Court disciple, I will come to your living quarters instead so that we can practice together. Where do you live?" Disciple Fei asked him later.

"Building #70," Yuan answered with a calm face.

"That area, huh? Well, it's not too surprising since you have a gold identification token. Okay, I'll see you there first thing tomorrow morning!" Disciple Fei said.

Sometime later, Yuan left her house and the Inner Court, returning back to his own house.

'A music competition, huh? How long has it been since I'd last participated in one...?' Yuan thought to himself. As someone who has participated in hundreds of competitions before, he couldn't help but feel excited about participating in another competition after so long.

Once Yuan left, Disciple Fei also left her house to seek out Elder Shan, her Master.

"Master, I have something important to tell you."

"Hm? Disciple Fei? What's the matter?" Elder Shan stopped working and looked at her.

"This is regarding the zither competition next week."

/p>

"Oh, right, the one backed by the Heaven and Earth Palace. What about it? If I recall correctly, you are required to bring a partner this time. Did you find one yet?" Elder Shan asked her.

Disciple Fei nodded and said, "Yes, I found someone, and he's that Disciple Yuan I mentioned not too long ago."

"D-Did you just say Disciple Yuan?!" Elder Shan exclaimed in a shocked manner.

"Y-Yes... Is there a problem with that?" Disciple Fei asked with a nervous look on her face.

Elder Shan did not immediately respond to her and silently pondered with a deep frown.

A moment of silence later, Elder Shan spoke, "Disciple Yuan... What did he say?"

"Uhhh... He'd agreed to participate in the competition with me," she responded.

"I see..." Elder Shan closed her eyes and sighed.

After another moment of silence, Elder Shan stood up and said, "Follow me."

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"Eh? Where are we going, Master?" Disciple Fei raised her eyebrows as she followed Elder Shan outside.

"To meet with the Sect Master."

"The Sect Master?! W-Why?! Did I do something wrong?!" Disciple Fei exclaimed with a nervous look on her face because only disciples who are in deep trouble with the sect would meet the Sect Master.

"Calm down, you're not in trouble. This is about Disciple Yuan. I don't know how much you know about him but I'm sure that you can tell that his existence within the sect is a unique one." Elder Shan said to her.

"D-Disciple Yuan? Is he's really that special?" Disciple Fei looked at her with a dumbfounded face.

"Special is an understatement, my dear disciple. You'll understand more about him in just a moment." Elder Shan said as she brought Disciple Fei to the Sect Master's headquarters.

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Chapter 167 - What Did He Do This Time?

"Sect Master, this is Elder Shan. I have something important to talk about regarding Disciple Yuan," Elder Shan knocked on Long Yijun's door and said from the outside.

"Disciple Yuan? What did he do this time?" Long Yijun immediately sighed and stopped working.

"Come inside!"

Elder Shan opened the door a moment later and entered the room with Disciple Fei following behind her.

"Hm?" Long Yijun raised his eyebrows after seeing Disciple Fei, wondering what she's doing there and how she's related to this situation.

"Disciple Fei, go ahead and tell the Sect Master what you told me before coming here," Elder Shan looked at her and said.

Disciple Fei nodded and stepped forward before bowing to Long Yijun in a respectful manner, "Core Disciple Fei greets the Sect Master."

After greeting Long Yijun, Disciple Fei began to speak, "I will be participating in the zither competition that will be held in a week with my partner, an Outer Court disciple surnamed Yuan."

"Zither competition? With Disciple Yuan?" Long Yijun's jaw loosened a little bit after hearing her words. Since when did Yuan become a zither expert?

Disciple Fei nodded and said, "Disciple Yuan has outstanding talents with the zither, and I believe that we have a good chance of obtaining third place if he participated in the competition with me."

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"Third place? If I recalled correctly, you'd placed 7th place for the last competition," Long Yijun said with a pondering face.

"That's correct, Sect Master."

After pondering for a moment, Long Yijun spoke, "I am aware that this competition is being backed by the Heaven and Earth Palace, so the competition will be much fiercer this year. What makes you think you will be able to achieve 3rd place?"

"If you'd listened to Disciple Yuan playing the zither, you would understand my feelings, Sect Master. I... I'd managed to obtain zither enlightenment after listening to his zither play."

"What?! Enlightenment? Just like that?!" Long Yijun exclaimed in a shocked voice, as this is his first time hearing of such a thing.

Disciple Fei nodded.

'Maybe I should also listen to Disciple Yuan play the zither...' Long Yijun thought to himself.

Sometime later, Long Yijun said, "Anyway, I understand the situation now, but letting Disciple Yuan leave the sect is not as simple as you think, Disciple Fei, as his existence within the sect is... a little special to say the least..."

"If I may ask, just who is Disciple Yuan, exactly? He's clearly someone with an important background, but I do not recognize him at all, nor have I ever heard of someone like him!" Disciple Fei said.

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Long Yijun took a deep breath before speaking, "To tell you the truth, Disciple Fei, we also have no clue as to what Disciple Yuan's true background is. There are speculations that he's from one of the Four Ancient Families, but that is only a speculation at best."

"The Four Ancient Families?!" Disciple Fei's jaw dropped after hearing this.

Even if it is only speculation, it was still incredibly shocking that they'd evaluate Yuan as someone worthy enough to exist in one of the Four Ancient Families.

After a moment of silence, Disciple Fei asked Long Yijun with a worried look on her face, "Then what's going to happen now? Are you going to forbid him from participating in the competition?"

"What? Of course not!" Long Yijun quickly responded with a surprised look on his face.

Although he won't say it because it would affect his face and position as the Sect Master, he actually didn't dare to confine Yuan inside the sect despite his value to them, especially after promising him that they would not restrict his movements and freedom.

"Then he can participate in the competition with me?" Disciple Fei asked again with a slightly excited look on her face.

"If that's what he wants to do, there's no reason for me to refuse, especially if you are so confident that you would achieve 3rd place in the tournament. After all, any reputation or recognition you gain from the competition will also affect the Dragon Essence Temple." Long Yijun nodded.

He then turned to look at Elder Shan and said, "I hope you don't mind, and I am not doubting your abilities, but since Disciple Yuan will be coming with you, I want Elder Xuan to accompany you just in case."

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Elder Shan nodded and said, "Don't worry, I completely understand. I won't be able to sleep for the rest of my life if anything were to happen to him while we are outside. In fact, even if you didn't mention it, I would've personally asked for help."

Long Yijun nodded and said a moment later, "Then I will look forward to your results, Disciple Fei."

"Thank you, Sect Master. I will try my best to bring glory to the Dragon Essence Temple." Disciple Fei bowed before leaving the place with Elder Shan shortly after.

"Zither competition, huh? I just hope that he doesn't make a commotion there..." Long Yijun sighed as he laid back on his seat, experiencing an uneasy feeling in his chest for some reason.

After leaving the Sect Master's headquarters, Disciple Fei asked Elder Shan, "Master, do you really think Disciple Yuan belongs to one of the Four Ancient Families?"

"Honestly, I have a feeling that his true background might even surpass that of the Four Ancient Families. You weren't there to witness it, but Disciple Yuan's cultivation talent... It's so ridiculously insane that it's scary."

"Above the Four Ancient Families? Does a power like that even exist in the Lower Heavens? I thought the Four Ancient Families are the strongest within the Lower Heavens." Disciple Fei said.

Elder Shan shook her head and said, "The Lower Heavens may seem small compared to the upper heavens, but there are many powerful and hidden backgrounds in this world that prefer to remain lowkey or unknown to the rest of the world as a method of survival, and the Four Ancient Families is just scratching the surface of what might exist— at least that's what I think."

Chapter 168 - Abandoned Shed

After returning to her own place, Elder Shan asked Disciple Fei, "What are you going to do now?"

"I am going to prepare myself for the competition and practice my zither arts with Disciple Yuan until then. If what he said is true— that he has never played the zither before until very recently, I believe that his skills will reach an unbelievably high level within a week before the tournament."

"W-Wait a second... Did you just say Disciple Yuan has only recently started playing the zither?" Elder Shan looked at her with wide eyes.

Disciple Fei nodded and said, "I know it's really hard to believe such words, but I don't see a reason for him to lie, and he doesn't seem to be the kind of person to lie about such things."

"Hard to believe? Haha! That's hardly true!" Elder Shan suddenly began laughing, dumbfounding her.

And she continued a moment later, "With his comprehension skills, it would be more shocking if he doesn't learn so quickly!"

"I-Is that so?" Disciple Fei mumbled in a slightly dazed word.

"Anyway, you can leave now and prepare for the competition. I'm already being overworked by the Sect Master because of the Mystic Realm. If I don't finish this work before your competition starts, things will get even more complicated for me!" Elder Shan sighed.

"Then I won't bother you any longer. Thank you, Master, for your time." Disciple Fei bowed to Elder Shan before leaving the place and returning to her own home to prepare.

Elder Shan shook her head with a bittersweet smile before returning to her own work.

/p>

Meanwhile, after returning to his own home, Yuan logged off the game and proceeded to cultivate in the real world until Yu Rou returned from school.

"Brother! I have some big news!" Yu Rou came into his room shouting.

"What's the matter?" Yuan asked.

"I just saw this from the forums as I was coming home, but there's going to be some sort of large competition that'll be happening in the Eastern Continent sometime next week, and it's related to playing the zither! Rumors have it that you can obtain a Divine-rank technique if you achieve first place!" Yu Rou said to him.

"Oh, that zither competition? I know about it since I will be participating in it." Yuan responded in a calm manner.

"WHAT?!"

Yu Rou nearly tripped on herself after hearing Yuan's unexpected words.

"Y-You're going to participate in a music competition again?!" Yu Rou exclaimed afterward, her gaze on Yuan filled with shock and excitement.

"It's only a competition inside the game, and I doubt I will be able to achieve any good results since I have only learned about the zither only very recently," Yuan said.

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"You're underestimating yourself, brother! Did you forget who you are? The number one musical prodigy who has mastered dozens of instruments from around the world before the age of seven! One week is more than enough for you to completely master the zither!" Yu Rou said.

"If I recall correctly, you'd even mastered the piano in less than 3 days!"

"Genius, huh? I don't really like to associate myself with that word, but that's probably because I have been called such a word countless times that I am tired of hearing it," Yuan sighed.

"There's nothing you can really do about it, brother. What do you expect to do? Call you the opposite of what you are? If you're a genius, people will naturally call you one." Yu Rou said.

And she continued, "The only other way is to not let people know that you are a genius, but brother, that's easier said than done. How does one even hide their talents? Especially someone like you... Even an ignorant person would be able to tell that you are a genius just by your performance at something."

"Anyway, you'll be participating in this zither competition, right? Although you can't see my face right now, I am actually really bitter that I won't be able to witness your brilliance in the competition, brother." Yu Rou sighed.

"Don't worry, there will always be another chance," Yuan said.

"I hope so..."

Sometime later, after dinner, Yu Rou left Yuan's room, but she didn't immediately return to her own room like usual and instead took a detour to a large shed behind the main house with Meixiu follow behind her.

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"Young Lady, this place is..." Meixiu looked at this shed with a perplexed look on her face. Why did Yu Rou suddenly decide to come to this place? It has been many years since they visited this seemingly abandoned shed.

"Do you have the key for the lock?" Yu Rou asked her.

"Yes. Here is the key, Young Lady." Meixiu handed her a somewhat rusty key the next moment.

A few seconds later, Yu Rou unlocked the heavy lock that kept the doors closed for many years before walking inside and flipping a switch.

After a few flickers, the light turned on, revealing the inside of the shed that had many shelves and display cases placed inside, and sitting on these display cases were golden trophies of all sizes and shapes that were won from small contests to major competitions with all of them related to music.

"No matter how many times I come here and look at these trophies, this breathtaking scenery always leaves me speechless," Yu Rou mumbled in a low voice as she approached these display cases and looked at the golden trophies.

[Awarded to Yu Tian for taking 1st place in the 23rd National Piano Competition]

[Awarded to Yu Tian for his breathtaking performance during 'Battle of Talents']

[Awarded to Yu Tian for ranking 1st place in the Rising Stars Grand Prix]

/p>

Over three hundred of such trophies filled the shelves and display cases inside the large shed, turning it into some sort of trophy museum. One can only imagine how long it'd take to collect all of these trophies even for a group of geniuses, let alone a single prodigy— Yu Tian— whose name occupied every single golden trophy in this room without a single one of them ranking below 1st place!

Chapter 169 - Trophy Room

"I haven't been to this place ever since Brother Tian stopped participating in competitions..." Yu Rou sighed while surrounded by hundreds of golden trophies.

"Then why did the Young Lady suddenly decide to return to this place?" Meixiu couldn't help but ask her out of curiosity.

Hearing her words, Yu Rou turned around with a beautiful smile on her face, and she said, "Because he'll be participating in a competition soon!"

"Participating... in a competition? The Young Master?" Meixiu looked at her with a dazed look on her face, unsure of how to think or feel about this.

"Yes! Brother Tian will be participating in a music competition inside Cultivation Online! Although it's not a real competition, it's the closest thing we'll get!"

"The Young Master... participating in a competition..." Meixiu mumbled with a profound look on her face, seemingly in deep thoughts.

Sometime later, Yu Rou clapped her hands together and bowed to the trophies in the room before mumbling in a sincere voice, "Good luck, brother... Let the cultivation world know of your musical talents..."

After spending a couple more minutes admiring Yuan's trophy room, Yu Rou locked the doors before returning to her own room.

"By the way, do you want to play Cultivation Online with me?" Yu Rou suddenly asked Meixiu.

"Me? Play games with the Young Lady? I wouldn't dare..." Meixiu quickly shook her head with a scared look on her face.

"Why not? You can consider it as work since you'll be 'serving' me inside the game instead of the real world. Furthermore, I know how hard you work for me, so I want you to relax and have fun sometimes." Yu Rou said to her.

"But... my mother..." Meixiu sighed.

"If you're worried about your mother scolding you, I will personally talk with her later."

"Thank you, Young Lady..." Meixiu nodded.

Although she doesn't show her emotions often or complain at all because of the way she was raised as a maid, Meixiu is also a young lady just like Yu Rou who has desires and aspirations, and while she doesn't show it, she's actually quite jealous of Yuan who can play games all day, not including his condition.

"Don't even mention it! I should be the one thanking you!" Yu Rou said as she entered the bed.

"Goodnight, Young Lady." Meixiu closed the lights before leaving Yu Rou's room and returning to her own and immediately going to sleep, as she has to wake up earlier than Yu Rou and prepare breakfast for her.

The following morning, after his morning routine, Yuan returned to Cultivation Online and waited for Disciple Fei to arrive at his house so that they could practice with the zither.

Meanwhile, after she'd prepared for the day, Disciple Fei left her home with her zither in her hands. While she can store the zither in her storage pouch or spatial ring, she preferred carrying it around more, as it made her feel more authentic as a zither expert.

"Look! It's Fairy Fei! She must be going to the Dragon Pavilion today!"

The disciples immediately jumped in joy when they saw Disciple Fei in the Outer Court, and because it has been many days since her last performance, it made them feel even more excited.

"Finally! I have been waiting for her to return to the Dragon Pavilion! Her zither arts must have improved even more since her last performance! I cannot wait to listen to her play!"

"Me too! I was going to train my sword techniques at the practice area, but I'll save that for another day!"

Thus, news of Fairy Fei returning to the Dragon Pavilion spread throughout the sect like wildfire, causing disciples from around the sect to gather at the Dragon Pavilion, crowding the place.

However, little did these disciples know that Disciple Fei had no intentions of going to the Dragon Pavilion anytime soon and that she was actually going to an Outer Court disciple's house today which would definitely cause mayhem if found out.

"Where's Fairy Fei? I heard that she was going to show up here today!"

"I don't know, I saw her in the Outer Court carrying her zither, but I came here as fast as possible to get a decent seat so I don't know where she actually went."

"Fuck! You mean to tell me that you'd only seen her walking around in the Outer Court!? She could've gone anywhere! What made you think she was coming to the Dragon Pavilion?!"

"Don't ask me! I was not the one who spread the rumor!"

A commotion occurred in the Dragon Pavilion when Fairy Fei hadn't shown up even after waiting for over an hour.

While the disciples that could not afford to dine in the Dragon Pavilion could not complain because they were all standing outside for free, the disciples that'd paid to sit inside the Dragon Pavilion were livid about Fairy

Fei's absence and even looked like they were bloodthirsty afterward, as they'd wasted contribution points due to some unfounded rumor that Fairy Fei would show up, feeling like they'd been played.

Meanwhile, Fairy Fei strolled in the opposite direction of the Dragon Pavilion, slowly approaching Yuan's building.

"Hmm? Who's that?" Min Li noticed Fairy Fei's beautiful figure in the distance from the window, mostly because of her Core Disciple uniforms that stood out.

"T-That's a Core Disciple! What's someone like that doing in the Outer Court?" Min Li mumbled to herself as she watched Disciple Fei approach her building.

"Huh? Is she here for me?" Min Li raised her eyebrows when Disciple Fei suddenly stopped in front of her house to look around, looking like she was searching for something.

A few moments later, Disciple Fei began moving again, but she'd only walked a few more steps before stopping again.

"T-That's Disciple Yuan's house! Is she here for him? But why is a Core Disciple looking for him?" Min Li pondered with a frown on her face.

"W-What if she's his partner? Maybe this is about my offer to him!" Min Li cried, feeling somewhat paranoid.

Meanwhile, Fairy Fei approached the doorsteps and knocked on the doors.

Chapter 170 - Practicing For The Competition

After hearing the door being knocked on, Yuan went to open the doors and greeted Disciple Fei.

"Hello, Disciple Fei. Come inside." Yuan invited her inside with a nonchalant look on his face.

Disciple Fei nodded and entered the building.

Sometime later, once they were sitting in the living room, and Yuan asked her, "So? What are we going to do, Disciple Fei?"

"First and foremost, you can stop calling me 'Disciple Fei'. Although it's only temporary, I am now your partner," she said in a calm voice.

"Then what am I supposed to call you?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"Fei Yuyan, that is my name, and you will call me as such when we are alone," she said with a stern look on her face as she glared at Yuan.

Yuan nodded without thinking too much about it and said, "Okay, Fei Yuyan. What are we going to do now?"

A moment later, Fei Yuyan placed her zither on the table and said, "What else? We're going to practice the zither for the entire week until the competition!"

Yuan looked at her with raised eyebrows, and he said, "We're both going to use the same zither? Wouldn't it be better if there was another one?"

"Of course not! I know you probably don't have a zither, so I brought an extra one with me." Fei Yuyan said as she retrieved another zither from her spatial ring.

"You'll be using this one for now. Everyone at the competition will be provided with a zither of similar quality so you don't need to worry about unfair conditions because you don't have a good zither."

Yuan nodded and looked at the familiar-looking zither, as it was the one he'd first played at the Dragon Pavilion.

"Anyway, before we begin our practice, allow me to explain a little more about the zither competition in more depth."

"First and foremost, there will be three main judges— each of them a top zither expert with hundreds of years of experience under their belt so you can expect a fairly accurate judgment for your skills. Of course, you won't see them until the final part of the exam."

"The previous competition was split into three parts, and we will be graded for each part. In the end, whoever has the most points will win the competition, simple as that."

"However, they might do things differently this year because of the Heaven and Earth temple. Furthermore, we will have a partner this time, so anything can happen."

Yuan nodded and asked, "What did you do last year?"

"We were graded on our hand techniques for the first part, so how you play the zither will be very important."

"If you do not meet their expectations, there's a good chance that you might not be able to proceed to the second round so keep that in mind."

"For the second part, you will be given one hour to memorize and play a random song that will be provided for you. Once again, if your performance is not satisfactory, they will fail you on the spot."

"By the time you reach the final part, there will only be a dozen participants remaining at best. And as for the final part for the competition, if you can make it there, you'll have to play the zither with one of the judges."

"Huh? Playing music with the judge?" Yuan raised his eyebrows in a surprised manner, as this is the first time that he's ever heard of such a thing in a music competition.

Fei Yuyan nodded and said, "One of the judges will pick a song, and you'll have ten minutes to memorize the song. Once time's up, the judge will play the song and you will follow along, and you will have points deducted for every mistake made. The judge will not stop playing even if you make a mistake, but if you suddenly stop playing, you will automatically fail, so you must continue playing the zither even if you make a mistake."

"Wow... What an interesting way to do a musical competition..." Yuan mumbled with a somehow excited smile on his face.

Fei Yuyan shook her head at him and said, "I know it sounds fun, but it's actually really difficult. I myself made over a dozen mistakes during the song. Furthermore, the judge's performance will easily distract you because of how amazing it sounds."

"Anyways, let's start practicing now. We don't have much time before the competition. For today, we'll take turns playing the zither just to get ourselves familiarized with each other's playstyle. Starting tomorrow, we'll begin practicing for the competition for real."

Yuan nodded.

"Then I will start first."

Fei Yuyan took a deep breath, and she began playing the zither shortly after.

A few minutes later, she said to Yuan, "It's your turn now. Try to play the song I'd just played even if you don't know it. This will be good practice just in case you'll have to do the same during the competition."

Yuan nodded and closed his eyes to recall every music note Fei Yuyan had played and all of her hand movements.

A few moments later, Yuan began moving his fingers on the zither strings, following Fei Yuyan's movements perfectly.

'This Disciple Yuan... He's really a genius...' Fei Yuyan mumbled to herself as she silently admired Yuan's zither skills.

Even though this is her first time playing this song in public, Yuan had managed to play the song perfectly without missing a single note, perhaps even slightly better.

"What do you think?" Yuan asked her afterward.

"Good enough," Fei Yuyan responded with a stiff expression on her face.

"I will now play the next song."

Fei Yuyan began playing a few seconds later, and Yuan started playing after she stopped, repeating the song.

They repeated this for the entire day, playing over 100 different songs by the end of the day.

'T-This guy is a freaking monster!' Fei Yuyan stared at Yuan with wide eyes and her body sweaty from playing the zither so much.

Chapter 171 - Is This Breaking The Sect Rules?

'T-This guy! Why is he so good with the zither?!' Fei Yuyan cried inwardly after their practice session ended.

'We played over a hundred songs and I'd made mistakes for a third of them, but alas, this guy! This guy managed to not only repeat my songs after hearing it once, but he'd even done so flawlessly without any mistakes! How the heck is that even possible?!'

One normally wouldn't be able to pinpoint mistakes in something they're not familiar with, so it was only normal to assume that Yuan wouldn't be able to pick out her mistakes when he has never heard of the song before. However, that was not the case, and to Fei Yuyan's surprise, Yuan had managed to do just that!

"It's been years since I've last played an instrument for such a long time without many breaks. It's really refreshing," Yuan said as he wiped the sweat from his forehead with a satisfied look on his face.

"You have played before?" Fei Yuyan looked at him with wide eyes, and she continued, "I thought you were new to the zither."

Yuan nodded and said, "Indeed, I am new to the zither. The first time I heard of the zither was at the Dragon Pavilion almost a week ago, much less touch one. However, I am not new to music since I used to play it professionally. As for the instruments... they're mostly nothing like the zither."

"What do you mean by playing it 'professionally'?" Fei Yuyan asked with her eyebrows lifted in a puzzled manner, as the concept of 'professional' musicians was not a thing in this cultivation world.

"It's when I play a certain instrument on a stage before tens of thousands of people, sometimes even millions," Yuan briefly explained.

"How is that any different from what we are about to do in the competition? After all, there will surely be hundreds of thousands of people watching you." Fei Yuyan asked.

Yuan shook his head and said, "The only difference is that it's not a competition. There's only you and the audience, and it's almost a routine, as we travel around the world."

"What? Travel around the world to play music for people? I don't understand what you'd get from that besides reputation because it sounds like a waste of time for me." Fei Yuyan shrugged.

Traveling around the world sounded very time-consuming, and as Cultivators, it sounded like a pain to travel around the world to play music for others, even if she loved the zither.

"Where I am from, it's nowhere as vast as the cultivation world so traveling around the world is not as crazy as it sounds."

"Where are you from, anyway?" Fei Yuyan noticed this chance to ask him about his background and directly went for it without any hesitation.

"I am from a faraway land called Earth..." Yuan said with a nonchalant look on his face.

'Earth? Never heard of such a place...' Fei Yuyan wondered to herself what kind of place was this and if it existed in the Lower Heavens or somewhere in the upper heavens.

"What about your family?" she asked him a moment later.

"My family? They're just regular people and musicians," Yuan said.

"M-Musicians? So you come from a family line of musicians?" Fei Yuyan mumbled in a dazed voice. It's no wonder he was so talented with the zither, as it appears that he was from a family who specializes in music!

Of course, Fei Yuyan had no clue that Yuan's parents were only ordinary mortals and that they've never cultivated before. If she'd known this, she would've definitely reacted a lot more differently.

After talking to Yuan some more, Fei Yuyan stood up and said, "Where's the bathroom? I am going to take a shower."

"Uh... It's over there..." Yuan pointed to a certain room in the building without thinking too much about her words.

Fei Yuyan nodded and said, "I will be right back."

Yuan nodded and said, "Then I will continue practicing the zither for a little bit longer."

Thus, Fei Yuyan went to the bathroom to clean the sweat she'd accumulated whilst Yuan played the zither, making Fei Yuyan spend more time in the bathroom than she'd anticipated because she accidentally absorbed herself in Yuan's performance.

'Third place is definitely achievable if I have someone like him as my partner!' Fei Yuyan tightly grasped her hands into fists with motivation and excitement on her face.

Sometime later, Fei Yuyan returned to the living room with a fresh appearance, looking like a fairy more than ever.

"You can use the bathroom now," she said to Yuan.

Yuan nodded, but he didn't immediately leave, as he waited until he finished the song before he stood up and walked to the bathroom.

Fei Yuyan looked at the zither that Yuan had been using for practice, and to her surprise, the ordinary zither was emitting a joyful aura, almost like it was satisfied by Yuan's performance!

'This is... I have only heard of Zither Masters being able to achieve such a thing— giving auras to the instruments they play, yet he...' Fei Yuyan stared at the zither with a shocked face.

Sometime later, once Yuan also returned with a fresh appearance, Fei Yuyan suddenly asked him, "Do you have an empty room?"

"An empty room? There are plenty in this large house, but why do you ask?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"In order to practice efficiently, I have decided to live here until the competition, so that is what I shall be doing. You don't mind, right?" Fei Yuyan said with a slightly nervous look on her face, clearly aware of the risks behind her decision.

"Uhh..." Yuan was speechless. She wanted to live in the same house as him? Although he didn't mind it, would they be breaking any sect rules by doing such a thing?

"Give me a moment... I want to make sure that we're not breaking any sect rules by doing this" Yuan said as he closed his eyes to recall the rulebook.

"S-Sect rules?" Fei Yuyan stared at him with a gawking look on her face, clearly in disbelief.

Chapter 172 - A Lot Can Happen In A Single Night

After taking a moment to recall the sect rules, Yuan opened his eyes and spoke in a nervous voice, "According to the sect rules, male and female disciples are forbidden to share the same living quarters unless they are married or have a high-ranking sect elder's permission, and the punishment is at most 3 months of confinement in the Disciplinary Cave..."

Fei Yuyan was speechless. Albeit subtly, did Yuan really just refuse her company in his house? What kind of man would refuse to let a beautiful girl stay in their house even if they might receive punishment? If it were any other men that were in Yuan's shoes right now, they would definitely let Fei Yuyan stay in their living quarters without hesitation even if they were to get kicked out of the sect the following day!

Fei Yuyuan then spoke with a slight frown on her face, "That rulebook is outdated— it was created thousands of years ago and nobody except a few really even follows it anymore, especially the Inner Court disciples. Furthermore, as a Core Disciple, I have more leeway in the sect. In other words, I can do almost whatever I want without restrictions if it doesn't affect the sect."

"And I highly doubt that living in a house with a male disciple will affect the sect in any way. Therefore, you can just ignore it."

"Even if you say that, I think it'd be for the best if we received permission from one of the sect elders, as you can never be too safe or you might regret it in the future. I know a few of them, so I can ask them." Yuan suddenly retrieved Elder Xuan's jade slip and activated it using his spiritual energy.

"Uhhh... Senior Xuan, can you hear me?" Yuan spoke to the jade slip.

Meanwhile, sitting behind his desk inside his living quarters, Elder Xuan felt the jade slip in his robes tremble, causing him to stop working and look at it.

'Hm? Disciple Yuan? Did something happen to him?' Elder Xuan frowned with a worried look on his face, wondering what Yuan had done this time.

"Senior Xuan, can you hear me? I hope I am not bothering you," Yuan's voice resounded from the jade slip a moment later.

"Yes, I can hear you. What happened?" Elder Xuan asked him.

"Well..." Yuan proceeded to explain the situation to Elder Xuan, dumbfounding him greatly.

'What the heck? Core Disciple Fei? What's she doing at his house? And why are they staying together? Don't tell me that they're...' Elder Xuan stared at the jade slip with wide eyes filled with shock.

"Anyway, do you think she can stay here? It'll only be for a week at most," Yuan asked him again afterward.

"A-Ahem! I don't see the problem." Elder Xuan said in a stiff voice after clearing his throat, and he continued, "Whatever you do inside, just try to keep it contained within the house."

"Eh? I understand...?" Yuan said, sounding a little confused by Elder Xuan's words.

Once Yuan ended the communication, Elder Xuan slumped back in his seat and sighed, "I told him to remain lowkey for a while, and he ends up bringing a female disciple into his home, even wanting to let her stay there for an entire week, and this disciple is even a Core Disciple..."

"Well, I cannot blame the guy. Talented people like him will attract women as easily as breathing."

After a moment of silence, Elder Xuan retrieved another jade slip before activating it and speaking to it, "My granddaughter, can you hear me?"

A few moments later, Xuan Wuhan's sleepy voice resounded, "What's the matter, grandpa? I don't plan on returning to the sect until next week even if you beg me."

Elder Xuan sighed and said, "This is about Disciple Yuan..."

"Oh? Yuan?! How's he doing in the sect? Nobody's bullying him, right?" Xuan Wuhan's voice immediately sounded much more energetic after hearing Yuan's name.

"Yeah, he's doing great. In fact, he's doing so great that he'd managed to woo a Core Disciple to stay at his house for an entire week! If you continue to laze around at home, someone will definitely take Yuan before you can do anything, and with his otherworldly talents, there will be some very powerful contenders."

"W-WHAT?!" Xuan Wuhan's voice resounded in a shocked manner after, almost like she'd just heard something impossible.

"I-Is that true, grandpa?! Who's this Core Disciple!" Xuan Wuhan's obviously panicked voice resounded from the jade slip, causing it to tremble.

"I don't know. I only know that he'd asked me for permission to allow a female Core Disciple to stay in his living quarters for a week. As for the reason, I have no clue since I didn't bother to ask." Elder Xuan lied with a straight face, as he knew very well it was Fei Yuyan that was at Yuan's house.

"And you agreed?! Why did you do something like that, grandpa?!" Xuan Wuhan exclaimed.

"What else was I supposed to do? Refuse? This is a Core Disciple and Disciple Yuan that we're talking about. I may be a Grand Elder, but there

are some things even I have no control over, especially when Disciple Yuan is involved."

After a moment of silence, Elder Xuan asked, "Well? Do you feel like coming back to the sect now?"

"I...I will be back in three days!" Xuan Wuhan responded a moment later in a resolute voice.

"Three days, huh? A lot can happen in a single night, much less three days, my granddaughter." Elder Xuan said, trying his best to not burst out laughing from teasing Xuan Wuhan.

"Fine! I'll come back now, okay?! Anyway, I'm leaving!"

The jade slip turned lifeless after Xuan Wuhan ended the communication with Elder Xuan.

"Silly little girl..." Elder Xuan shook his head as he placed the jade slip back into his robes.

Meanwhile, Yuan said to Fei Yuyan with an innocent smile on his face, "Now that we have permission, you can stay here without breaking any sect rules!"

"You are really... I don't even know what to say..." Fei Yuyan rubbed her eyes like she was exhausted.

Chapter 173 - Unable To Sleep

"Anyway, now that we have permission, I'll be staying here until the competition finishes." Fei Yuyan said to him in a slightly angry voice, clearly unhappy about the way Yuan had handled this situation.

"By the way, I won't be here at night and will return in the morning." Yuan suddenly said to her as she went to look for an empty room.

"What? Why not? Where are you going that requires you to stay outside all night?" Fei Yuyan asked him with raised eyebrows.

"I'm not going anywhere— I just won't be available until the morning," Yuan said.

"Is that so? I won't need you at night, anyway," Fei Yuyan quickly responded in a somewhat weird tone, and she left the place to look for her own room.

Sometime later, Fei Yuyan settled in the room that was only two doors away from Yuan's room.

"We will begin practice tomorrow morning at sunrise. Good night and get plenty of rest because we'll practice even harder tomorrow," Fei Yuyan said to Yuan before retiring inside her room.

However, Fei Yuyan was unable to sleep like she normally would, as this is her first time sleeping with another individual in the same building after she became an Inner Court disciple, much less a male disciple!

In fact, this is definitely her first time staying overnight at a man's house, and she would've never imagined that it'd belong to an Outer Court disciple either!

Meanwhile, after returning to his own room, Yuan logged off for the night and waited for Yu Rou to return from school.

After dinner was served and Yu Rou brushed his teeth, Yuan proceeded to spend the rest of the night cultivating.

However, inside cultivation online, only an hour after Yuan logged off, Xuan Wuhan appeared outside of the Dragon Essence Temple with an irritated frown on her face, looking like someone who'd their peace disturbed.

"S-Senior apprentice sister Xuan! Welcome back!" The guards standing at the entrance of the sect immediately bowed to Xuan Wuhan who was not only a Core Disciple but also Grand Elder Xuan's granddaughter, and it would not be an exaggeration to say that she was as famous if not even more popular than Fei Yuyan.

However, Xuan Wuhan ignored these guards and walked directly into the sect.

The guards turned to look at her with scared looks on their faces, and they wondered to themselves what had happened that made her appear so angry, as they have never seen her act in such a way before.

"Welcome back from your vacation, Senior apprentice sister Xuan!"

"Greetings, Fairy Xuan!"

"How was your vacation, Senior apprentice sister Xuan? I hope you enjoyed it because you earned it!"

Almost every disciple in the Outer Court recognized Xuan Wuhan and greeted her the moment they saw her, and even if the disciples didn't recognize her face they recognized her uniform that only Core Disciples are qualified to wear, so they still greeted her with respect.

"Thanks." Xuan Wuhan responded in a nonchalant manner before walking away with wide strides, dumbfounding these disciples.

"Did something happen to Fairy Xuan? She's usually cheerful and easy to approach, yet she's acting the total opposite today."

"Maybe something unpleasant happened during her vacation."

"Wait a second, I thought Fairy Xuan wouldn't return to the sect for another week? Maybe that has something to do with her behavior?"

"That must be it. I wonder if this is related to what happened not long ago at the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate."

"Maybe they are gathering all of the Core Disciples for a meeting."

"Do we know the identity of the disciple who cleared the tower yet?"

"No, not yet. The sect elders aren't saying anything but that's because they also don't know anything— at least that's what I was told when I asked some of them."

"What? Not even the sect elders are aware of the situation? This situation must be more complicated than we'd expected..."

"Think about it, this is the first time anyone has cleared all 100 floors in the tower, and even the Founder could only clear 99 floors, failing on the last floor. I doubt the sect would be willing to reveal a talent like that to the rest of the world right before the Mythic Realm."

"Oh, right. The Mythic Realm is only around the corner, huh? I cannot wait for this year's tournament. I heard a certain rumor that the other elite sects also accepted a couple of cultivation prodigies."

"Really? I wonder how they'll fare against our disciples."

"Hmph! Do you even need to ask that question? Of course, our disciples won't lose!"

"I guess..."

Sometime later, Xuan Wuhan arrived in the area Yuan lived in and looked around for building #70.

Meanwhile, Min Li, who was getting ready for bed, noticed Xuan Wuhan's appearance from her window.

"Isn't that Grand Elder Xuan's granddaughter? What's she doing here?" Min Li mumbled to herself as she tried her best to watch Xuan Wuhan from the window without being noticed.

Once she'd found her target, Xuan Wuhan approached building #70 and knocked on the door after stepping onto the doorstep.

However, when nobody answered the door even a minute later, Xuan Wuhan knocked on it again, this time with even more force.

'D-Don't tell me that they've already started doing 'that'?!?!?!' Xuan Wuhan cried inwardly, feeling uncomfortable all over her body for some reason.

"Yuan! Are you inside?!" Xuan Wuhan knocked on the door while shouting out loud, sounding a little bit desperate, "It's me! Xuan Wuhan! Hurry up and open the door!"

But alas, Yuan had long logged off the game and would not be able to hear her voice no matter how loud she shouted.

However, it was a different story for Fei Yuyan, who'd recently fallen asleep with much difficulty, and Xuan Wuhan's constant knocking eventually woke her up.

"Damn it! What kind of rude person would knock on the door so loudly this late?! And I'd finally managed to sleep too!"

Fei Yuyan quickly got off the bed and went downstairs before opening the door in an agitated manner.

"Who's barking so loudly in the middle of the night?! What are you, a dog?! Name yourself!" Fei Yuyan spoke in an angry voice as she opened

the door.

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Chapter 174 - Why Are You Here?

"Who are you calling a dog?! I am Xuan Wuhan, a Core Disciple!" Xuan Wuhan responded to Fei Yuyan's words.

"Disciple Xuan?" Fei Yuyan's eyes widened with surprise when she saw Xuan Wuhan's familiar face standing right in front of her, and she continued, "What are you doing here so late at night?"

"Eh? Disciple Fei?" Xuan Wuhan's eyes also widened with shock when she saw a familiar face.

She then looked at the building number to make sure that she was in the right place. However, she suddenly recalled that they were currently at the Outer Court. Even if this wasn't Yuan's building, what is a Core Disciple like Fei Yuyan doing here?

"You... This is Disciple Yuan's house, right?" Xuan Wuhan decided to ask her.

Fei Yuyan immediately began sweating cold sweats, and she stared at Xuan Wuhan with a nervous look on her face, clearly hesitant to tell the truth. However, since Xuan Wuhan mentioned Yuan's name, Xuan Wuhan is clearly related to him one way or another so there was no way she could lie in this situation.

"Y-Yes, this is Disciple Yuan's house..." Fei Yuyan answered after a moment of awkward silence.

"..."

After another moment of awkward silence, Xuan Wuhan spoke, "I-If you don't mind me asking, what are you doing in another disciple's house so

late at night? And a male disciple too..."

However, Fei Yuyan didn't answer her question and instead asked, "I-I can ask you the same... Why are you looking for Disciple Yuan so late in the night? I thought you wouldn't return to the sect until next week?"

Xuan Wuhan frowned slightly and said, "Well, my schedule has changed and I have returned now, okay? As for why I am here— I was the one who introduced Yuan to the Dragon Essence Temple. Of course, I would want to see how he's doing in the sect now that I have returned."

"What? You were the one who brought Yuan to the sect? Does this mean you know his background?" Fei Yuyan's eyes widened after hearing Xuan Wuhan's words.

"T-That's right! I know his background! I know everything about him!" Xuan Wuhan lied to Fei Yuyan without even thinking about it.

"Can you tell me? I've been trying to figure out his background, but I can only assume that he's from one of the Four Great Families..." Fei Yuyan sighed.

"F-Four Great Families? Yuan?" Xuan Wuhan looked at Fei Yuyan with a shocked look on her face.

"Eh? You mean he's not?" Fei Yuyan raised her eyebrows, looking a little suspicious of Xuan Wuhan's reaction.

"I-I am not telling you anything! After all, I'd promised him that I'd not reveal his identity to anyone! If you want to know so badly, why don't you ask him yourself?" Xuan Wuhan decided to play the 'it's a secret' card, narrowly escaping the hole she'd dug herself.

"Hmmm..." Fei Yuyan narrowed her eyes at Xuan Wuhan before shaking her head a moment later and saying, "Anyway, I don't have the time or energy to entertain you right now. If you're looking for Disciple Yuan, he's already retired for the night. Come back tomorrow morning."

Fei Yuyan proceeded to close the door on Xuan Wuhan's face, but a quick reaction from Xuan Wuhan's foot stopped the door from closing.

"Wait a second, I have answered your question, but you still haven't answered mine. What are you— a Core Disciple doing in Yuan's living quarters at this time? Don't tell me you're staying here?"

"Why does it matter? It's none of your business what I do with another disciple. But if answering your question will make you go away then yes, I am currently staying in Disciple Yuan's home for the time being."

Xuan Wuhan gritted her teeth at Fei Yuyan. Although there has been no enmity between the two of them before today, their current situation has definitely lowered their opinions of each other.

"Now if you don't have anything else, please go away. I would like to get back into my bed and sleep, something you disturbed with your rude knocking," Fei Yuyan said as she tried to close the door again.

However, Xuan Wuhan refused to move her foot, blocking Fei Yuyan from closing the door on her.

"What is your problem, Disciple Xuan? You may be the Grand Elder's granddaughter, but even you have to follow the sect rules, and what you're doing right now is definitely breaking the sect rules."

"What sect rule am I breaking, exactly?" Xuan Wuhan shamelessly asked her.

"You..." Fei Yuyan was speechless. Unlike Yuan, she did not memorize the rulebook, hence why she could not answer Xuan Wuhan's question.

"How about this? To make sure you're not defiling my innocent friend, I'll also stay in this house to keep watch." Xuan Wuhan suddenly suggested,

"D-Defile?! H-How dare you! Who do you think I am?! Why would I defile anyone?!" Fei Yuyan exclaimed. "And what are you, a guard dog?!"

"You're acting mighty suspicious, Disciple Fei. Why are you not telling me your reason for being here if you have nothing to hide?" Xuan Wuhan said with narrowed eyes.

"Because I..." Fei Yuyan rubbed her eyes and sighed.

"Fine, I'll tell you. Will you leave me alone if I do that?"

"Of course..." Xuan Wuhan nodded.

Fei Yuyan took a deep breath before explaining to Xuan Wuhan about the zither competition and Yuan becoming her partner, hence why she's staying over at his house— so they can practice more efficiently.

Xuan Wuhan was speechless after learning the situation, even feeling somewhat guilty for her behavior.

"I-I am sorry for misunderstanding the situation, but if it's only something like this, why did you try to hide it like you're doing something immoral?" Xuan Wuhan said afterward.

"I...I don't know..." Fei Yuyan said. "Anyway, I am too tired, and I still have practice tomorrow with Disciple Yuan. I am going to sleep. Goodbye."

"W-Wait a moment! One more thing!" Xuan Wuhan quickly said.

"What is it?" Fei Yuyan looked at her with a tired expression.

"Can I come tomorrow and watch you two practice?" Xuan Wuhan asked.

"Do whatever you want as long as it doesn't disturb our practice..." Fei Yuyan said before closing the door, leaving Xuan Wuhan standing outside with a dazed look on her face.

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Chapter 175 - Unexpected Guests

"Xuan Wuhan... What's her relationship with Disciple Yuan, really?" Fei Yuyan mumbled to herself as she entered her bed to sleep, but alas, it took her another hour to fall asleep again, mostly because she kept wondering about Xuan Wuhan and Yuan's relationship.

As for Xuan Wuhan, she reluctantly left the area, but she did not return to her own house. Instead, she went to bother Elder Xuan, her grandfather.

"Heavens... What did I just witness?" Min Li covered her mouth in shock after eavesdropping on Xuan Wuhan and Fei Yuyan's small argument. This is the first time she's ever heard of two Core Disciples arguing with each other over an Outer Court disciple.

'It's fine... Even though I may be at a disadvantage in terms of our disciple status, I will sooner or later become a Core Disciple, and I am also from one of the Seven Legacy Families! Furthermore, my appearance isn't worse than theirs— at least I don't think I am losing in that aspect!' Min Li thought to herself, trying to convince herself that she wasn't losing to Xuan Wuhan and Fei Yuyan, as they are clearly also trying to secure a place in Yuan's heart.

Meanwhile, in the real world, Yuan peacefully cultivated for the rest of the night, completely oblivious to the small drama that had occurred at his house between two top beauties in the Dragon Essence Temple.

Once morning came and Yu Rou returned to his room and finished her daily routine, Yuan returned to the game.

"Hm? She's still sleeping?" Yuan raised his eyebrows when he didn't see Fei Yuyan in the living room, as he'd expected her to be awake by now.

'Maybe she'd pushed herself too hard during yesterday's practice...' Yuan thought to himself.

Knock *Knock*

Somebody knocked on the door a few seconds after Yuan took a seat in the living room to wait for Fei Yuyan.

'Who could be here so early in the morning?' Yuan wondered to himself as he went to open the door.

"Hello, Disciple Yuan."

A familiar face greeted him at the door.

"Disciple Min? What's the matter?" Yuan asked her.

"Nothing important. I heard you playing the zither yesterday, and I just wanted to listen to it more clearly. Do you mind if I watch you play the zither today?" Min Li asked him whilst trying her best to not blush.

However, to Min Li's surprise, Yuan apologized to her, "Did our practice bother you yesterday? I hope it didn't disturb your cultivation, and I am really sorry if it did... And you could've at least let me know if it did..."

"Uhhh..." Min Li was slightly speechless.

Most buildings in the Dragon Essence Temple are enforced with formations that block sound from leaving or entering the house so that one wouldn't be able to disturb others during their cultivation or vice versa, so there was no way that Min Li could've heard Yuan playing the zither no matter how loud he played it.

"D-Don't worry about it, I really enjoyed it, or else I would've knocked on your door sooner." Min Li responded in a stiff voice a moment later.

Yuan nodded afterward and said, "I'm relieved. And you're definitely welcomed to watch us practice the zither today."

"Thank you, Disciple Yuan." Min Li said to him, pretending as though their recent conversation had never happened.

Knock *Knock*

And just as Min Li took a seat in the living room, the door was knocked on again.

"Who could it be this time?" Yuan raised his eyebrows, wondering why there were so many guests today.

"Hello, Yuan! It's been a while!" Xuan Wuhan greeted Yuan at the door this time.

"Xuan Wuhan!" Yuan was pleasantly surprised to see her face.

"What are you doing here?" Yuan asked her.

"What do you mean by that, Yuan? Am I, a fellow disciple of the sect, not supposed to be here?" Xuan Wuhan asked him.

Seeing Yuan's speechless face, Xuan Wuhan smiled and said, "I'm joking with you, Yuan. Anyway, I have heard about the zither competition and how you're going to participate in it with Disciple Fei, and I would like to watch you practice. After all, you'll need some audience to judge your performance, right?"

Hearing her words, Yuan nodded, "That makes sense. Although Disciple Fei hasn't woken up yet, please, come inside."

"She's still sleeping? What a lazy girl..." Xuan Wuhan took this opportunity to smear some dirt on Fei Yuyan's image.

Xuan Wuhan entered the building a moment later.

However, to her surprise, there was already another individual inside the living room.

"Y-You... Aren't you Min Li from the Seven Legacies Family? What are you doing here?" Xuan Wuhan looked at Min Li with wide eyes.

"I... I am here to listen to their practice." Min Li said.

"You? Don't you have better things to do as a member of the Seven Legacy Families?" Xuan Wuhan raised her eyebrows, and she stared at Min Li with a suspicious gaze.

"What does belonging to the Seven Legacy Families have anything to do with this?" Min Li responded calmly. Even though she was before a Core Disciple, she wasn't feeling scared or nervous like most disciples would be if they were in her shoes right now.

"..."

Xuan Wuhan was speechless, mostly because she had nothing good to say.

Sometime later, Xuan Wuhan said to Yuan, "If Disciple Fei doesn't wake up soon, I'll go knock on her door."

However, Yuan shook his head and said, "There's no need to wake her up. She practiced for many hours yesterday so she's definitely very tired."

"Then what about your practice?"

"I can still practice by myself. Let's go outside to the backyard so that we don't disturb Disciple Fei." Yuan suggested.

Xuan Wuhan nodded, and she followed Yuan outside with Min Li following behind her.

Once they were outside, Yuan sat behind the zither and prepared to play it.

Xuan Wuhan and Min Li swallowed nervously, feeling somewhat anxious to see Yuan play the zither for some reason.

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Chapter 176 - Overslept

Once the guests were seated and he was prepared to play the zither, Yuan placed his fingers on the zither and began pulling the strings, causing them to tremble and send out musical notes that massaged one's brain and transported their mind to the heavens.

Xuan Wuhan and Min Li's jaw simultaneously dropped to the ground when they heard Yuan playing the zither for the first time, looking like they'd just witnessed their ancestors crawling from their graves, and it'd only taken them a few seconds to recognize Yuan's talents.

'This guy...! He's not only talented in cultivation but he's also talented with instruments? Is there anything he's not talented in?' Xuan Wuhan cried inwardly.

'What amazing music that he's producing... Not even the expert musicians in my family can play the zither as well as he does...' Min Li thought to herself.

The two ladies quickly indulged themselves in Yuan's music, as did the disciples near that area once they heard Yuan's music, even stopping their movements to close their eyes and enjoy the music.

"Who's playing the zither? I thought it was Fairy Fei at first but the Dragon Pavilion isn't even close to this place!"

One of the disciples wandering outside asked the other disciples.

"Who else besides Fairy Fei would have the ability to play the zither to such an extent in the sect? Furthermore, I heard from some disciples that they'd spotted Fairy Fei in the Outer Court yesterday. Maybe she's playing the zither somewhere in the Outer Court!"

"If that's the case, I want to watch her performance!"

"Me too! Let's try to locate her!"

Thus, the Outer Court disciples, with their interest piqued, decided to follow the sound of the zither. Once they'd arrived at the area that housed the most important and privileged disciples in the Outer Court, these Outer Court disciples stopped and didn't dare to traverse any further.

"It's coming from this area, but normal disciples aren't allowed in this area..."

"This place is where all of the top disciples live, right? I think it'd be fine as long as we do not disturb them. After all, there is no sect rule stating that we cannot enter this place."

"You don't know? There have been many incidents where ignorant disciples would enter this place only to get beaten by the disciples living here, as they treat this place as some sort of sacred sanctuary where only the privileged are allowed to traverse. If you don't mind getting beaten, you can go ahead and enter this place."

When the other disciples heard such a thing, they immediately tossed the idea of entering this place out of their minds. Although they wanted to watch Fairy Fei's zither performance, it wasn't worth risking offending someone in this place and possibly their life as well.

"If we cannot enter this place, why don't we all just stand here and listen to the music instead? We don't really need to watch Fairy Fei perform it since we don't normally do that anyway."

"Sounds reasonable... Okay, I am staying here."

Thus, the disciples there decided to gather outside the area and quickly crowded the place.

Sometime later, inside Yuan's house, Fei Yuyan rubbed her eyes in a tired manner.

'What time is it...?' She opened her eyes and stared at the unfamiliar ceiling with a dazed face.

"Oh no! It's already way past morning! I was supposed to practice with Disciple Yuan! It's all that darn Disciple Xuan's fault that I'd overslept!" Fei Yuyan cried out loud when she saw the slightly orange sky outside, and she quickly fixed her appearance before running outside her room.

However, the entire house was dead silent, almost like she lived in this house alone.

Fei Yuyan went to knock on Yuan's door, but alas, nobody answered no matter how much she knocked.

"Where did he go?" Fei Yuyan frowned, wondering where Yuan could've gone at this time.

"Maybe he went to get food?"

With this in mind, Fei Yuyan went to wash her face before leaving the house.

However, the moment she opened the door, she could hear a heavenly sound that could only be played by a zither.

"T-This is...?" Fei Yuyan immediately turned around to look behind the building before closing the door and approaching the backyard.

Once she opened the door to the backyard, Yuan's zither music immediately flowed into her ears and caused her body to tremble with delight.

Yuan noticed Fei Yuyan's presence, but it did not distract his performance and he continued to play the song until the end.

At the end of the song, Yuan turned to look at the dazed Fei Yuyan and said to her with a smile on his face, "Good morning, Disciple Fei— or should I say good afternoon?"

Xuan Wuhan and Min Li turned to look at Fei Yuyan once they noticed her presence.

"Hm? So you're finally awake, huh? Took you long enough. Yuan has been practicing the zither this entire time without any breaks. At this rate, you'll be a burden to him in the competition," Xuan Wuhan said to Fei Yuyan while shaking her head.

"..."

Fei Yuyan immediately trembled in anger and shouted at Xuan Wuhan, "Whose fault do you think it is that I overslept?! If you didn't wake me up in the middle of the night by knocking on the door like a rude ape, I would've woken up on time!"

"W-Who are you calling an ape?! There are things you cannot say to a fellow sister no matter how angry you are!" Xuan Wuhan exclaimed.

"Shut up! I don't want to hear anything from you!" Fei Yuyan said.

"Calm down, there's no need to yell at each other." Yuan said to them with a slightly startled look on his face, and he continued while looking at Fei Yuyan, "There is still plenty of time until the day's over so it's not like you've wasted an entire day."

Fei Yuyan nodded and said in a casual voice, "I don't have the time to argue with an ape. I'm going to practice now."

"T-This bitc..." Xuan Wuhan gritted her teeth. While she wanted to yell at Fei Yuyan, she didn't want to disturb their practice, so she forcefully swallowed her anger and pretended like she never heard Fei Yuyan's insults.

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Chapter 177 - Otherworldly Music

"Anyway, since I've missed half of today's practice, let's do something different. I had planned on doing something similar to our practice yesterday, but alas..." Fei Yuyan sighed.

And she continued, "Do you remember what I said about last competition's final part— where you must follow the judge and play their song alongside them? This is what we're going to be doing today. I will play a song and you'll play alongside me."

Yuan nodded, and he asked afterward, "Are we going to play a new song?"

"Of course. The judges will create a new song just for the competition so nobody besides themselves would know the song beforehand, as that would give the participants an unfair advantage and we don't want that."

"Anyway, I will play the song once, and you'll have 10 minutes to prepare..." Fei Yuyan suddenly paused, and she said in an awkward voice a moment later, "But you've already been doing that even for yesterday's practice..."

"Ah... What should we do now? I was going to ask you to use new songs so I can follow you but do you even know any new songs?" Fei Yuyan asked Yuan, as she has been the one teaching him new songs this entire time.

"Hmmm..." Yuan pondered for a moment before nodding, "I think I can do that."

"Eh? Really? You know songs that even I don't know?" Fei Yuyan stared at him with a gawking look on her face, as she truly didn't expect that from him.

Yuan nodded and said, "I know a few songs from my hometown. Although I've never played them on the zither, it's not my first time playing the same song on different instruments."

"That's great! Let's hear one of them!" Fei Yuyan said with her interest piqued, silently wondering to herself what kind of music Yuan had prepared for her.

"Give me a moment... It's been a while since I've played those songs." Yuan closed his eyes and proceeded to recall some of the songs that he'd played in the real world when he was still active as a musician.

A few minutes later, with his eyes still closed, Yuan placed his fingers back on the zither and began playing the song from his memories.

"T-This... What kind of music is this?" Fei Yuyan's jaw dropped to the ground when she heard this song that was like nothing she has ever heard of before, almost like it was otherworldly.

While it's only normal for songs to not sound similar to each other, they mostly followed a similar theme or feeling, yet the song played by Yuan right now did not follow such rule and sounded oddly foreign.

As for Xuan Wuhan and Min Li, while they don't know much about music, they knew instantly how unique this song sounded purely from the atmosphere it created.

Hell, even the disciples gathered outside the area were dumbfounded by such a drastic change in music, feeling like they'd suddenly been tossed into another world.

A few minutes later, Yuan stopped his movements and turned to look at Fei Yuyan.

"What do you think?" he asked her.

"Uhh..." Fei Yuyan stared at him with a speechless look, clearly taken aback by the unfamiliar music.

"I-It sounds great... But... How am I supposed to play that kind of song? Are you teasing me right now?" Fei Yuyan said to him.

"Huh? What do you mean? Why would I be teasing you?" Yuan looked at her with wide eyes, as he didn't expect such a response from her.

"That song you just played is objectively extremely difficult, as it has many unique notes, and the speed you played it is also incredibly fast! There's no way I can play something that profound after hearing it once! Even the song created by the judges for the previous competition wasn't anything like this!" Fei Yuyan explained to Yuan her frustration.

"R-Really? It didn't feel like that for me..." Yuan pondered, and he continued a moment later, "Okay, I will try to play something that has less unique notes and with a slower pace in general."

After taking a deep breath, Yuan began playing another song that was from his world.

"Oh?"

Fei Yuyan raised her eyebrows after listening to this song. Although it still sounds foreign and otherworldly, it wasn't as chaotic and fast-paced as the previous song, allowing her mind to follow it properly.

Sometime later, after Yuan finished the song, Fei Yuyan said to him, "Okay, give me ten minutes."

Yuan nodded and patiently waited for Fei Yuyan to prepare herself.

Once Fei Yuyan was ready, she looked at Yuan and nodded her head while her fingers were already on the zither.

"Three... two... one..."

Ting~

Yuan and Fei Yuyan began playing the zither simultaneously, and Fei Yuyan tried her best to follow Yuan's pace, but alas, even someone inexperienced

with music like Xuan Wuhan and Min Li could tell that Fei Yuyan was falling behind and making mistakes.

Halfway into the song, Fei Yuyan suddenly stopped moving her fingers and stared at the zither with a slightly flushed face, embarrassed that she was unable to play any further.

'Damn it! I am the one that's supposed to be teaching him, not the other way around! When did our roles change?! And his performance is simply too flawless! I am barely able to play the song because his music would always distract me, tempting me to stop playing to fully focus on listening to his beautiful music! However, if I don't listen to his music, I won't be able to follow along! At this rate, I'll really be a burden in the competition!'

Once Fei Yuyan stopped playing the zither, Yuan also stopped before asking her, "Do you want to start again from the beginning?"

After a moment of silence, Fei Yuyan nodded in a bashful manner.

Xuan Wuhan chuckled when she saw this, "So much for the number one zither expert in the sect, Fairy Fei..."

Fei Yuyan's eyebrows twitched after hearing Xuan Wuhan's words, but she ignored it and pretended like she didn't hear it and prepared to play the zither again.

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Chapter 178 - Not Interested In Men

After taking a deep breath, Fei Yuyan began playing the zither again with Yuan, trying her best to synchronize her music with his, but alas, she stopped playing again somewhere in the middle of the song.

'This is too difficult!' Fei Yuyan cried inwardly with her back soaked in sweat despite barely practicing.

"It's okay, we can start again and do this until you can finish the song," Yuan said to her in a soothing tone, almost like he was trying to make her feel better.

However, Fei Yuyan shook her head and said, "Then that would make this entire practice pointless! If I cannot follow the judge after one try, I'll immediately fail!"

"But if you don't practice, how will you improve? It's called 'practice' for a reason."

"That's easy for a genius like you to say..." Fei Yuyan sighed.

"People may call me a genius, but I have spent more time practicing the instruments than anyone at my age when I was a mere child— even those twice or thrice my age. Every day, without fail, I would spend at least ten hours a day practicing different instruments, even on the days that I have competitions and whatnot." Yuan sighed after recalling the amount of time he'd spent practicing the instruments.

He'd spent so much time on instruments that his social life was basically nonexistent outside of his family and a small circle of people.

"Ten hours a day every day?"

Everybody there looked at him with wide eyes. How does he cultivate if he spends all of his time practicing instruments?

"Anyway, let's continue to practice. I'm sure you'll get it right soon or later. Once you get it right for the first time, it'll be much easier next time even if it's with a new song." Yuan said to Fei Yuyan, who nodded in a dazed manner.

Thus, the two of them continued to practice with Fei Yuyan trying her best to synchronize with Yuan's performance.

Of course, Fei Yuyan had stopped midway a couple more times, but there was clear progress, albeit rather slow.

After a dozen failures, Fei Yuyan finally managed to complete the song with Yuan, but her performance was still questionable at best with multiple mistakes.

Meanwhile, the disciples listening to their performance outside were puzzled by the weird noises coming from Yuan's building.

"Who's that second zither player? This amateur is ruining Fairy Fei's flawless performance!"

"Maybe Fairy Fei is teaching someone the zither."

"Aiya... What a damn pity and a waste of Fairy Fei's time..."

The disciples there complained about this 'amateur player', completely unaware that they were all dissing the same Fairy Fei that they were praising.

Meanwhile, somewhere in the Inner Court, Elder Shan looked at the pill in her hands with a proud expression on her face.

"I have finally completed this enhanced Pill of Concealment. Now I just need to give it to Disciple Yuan." Elder Shan mumbled to herself as she left her building and made her way towards Yuan's living quarters.

However, to her surprise, there were hundreds of Outer Court disciples gathered outside the area, dumbfounding Elder Shan when she witnessed this scene.

"What the heck is going on here?"

Elder Shan approached the crowd and spoke loudly, "What is the cause of this gathering?"

When the disciples turned around and saw Elder Shan's beautiful face, they immediately lowered their heads and greeted her.

"Greetings, Elder Shan!"

After their greetings, the disciples proceeded to explain their situation to her.

"What? My disciple is playing the zither in this area?" Elder Shan raised her eyebrows, then she recalled how Fei Yuyan's going to be participating in the zither competition with Yuan.

'She must be practicing with him, huh.' Elder Shan thought to herself before speaking out loud, "Well, this is not a place for disciples to gather. If you want to listen to her zither music, you can wait until she decides to visit the Dragon Pavilion! Now scram!"

Although they were reluctant to leave, there was simply no way these Outer Court disciples could defy a sect elder, much less a high-ranking sect elder like Elder Shan.

Once the disciples left the scene, they all mumbled to each other, "Man, this is my first time seeing Elder Shan in such a close distance! Her title as the prettiest sect elder is not for show!"

"I heard she was even the number one fairy back when she was still a young disciple! Man, if only I can have a partner like that!"

"Quit your dreaming! Don't you know that Elder Shan has no interest in men? Rumor has it that she's only interested in women, hence why she only accepts female disciples!"

"Really? Damn, what a pity! But that's also hot in its own ways!"

Sometime later, Elder Shan approached Yuan's building and knocked on the door, and she shouted loudly, "Disciple Fei! Come outside!"

"Eh? That sounds like my master. What's she doing here?" Fei Yuyan turned around with a puzzled look on her face. "And why did she call for me when this is clearly your house?"

Fei Yuyan then placed her zither down and went to open the door.

"Master? What are you doing here?" Fei Yuyan asked her after greeting her.

"I have something for Disciple Yuan," Elder Shan said, and she continued, "Are you guys practicing right now?"

"Yes, but since it's getting late, we're about to stop."

"Oh? I know it's only been two days but let me see your progress." Elder Shan said.

"I have been curious about Disciple Yuan's zither skills ever since you asked him to be your partner for the competition."

"Uhhh..." Fei Yuyan immediately hesitated, mostly because she didn't want Elder Shan to learn that Yuan has already surpassed her with the zither.

'Ah, whatever... She's going to learn about it sooner or later...' Fei Yuyan sighed inwardly before nodding her head.

A few moments later, Fei Yuyan returned to the backyard with Elder Shan by her side, dumbfounding Xuan Wuhan and Min Li.

"Hmm?"

Elder Shan also raised her eyebrows when she noticed the two of them, as she wasn't expecting any other guests other than herself.

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Chapter 179 - Enhanced Pill Of Concealment

"E-Elder Shan!" Xuan Wuhan and Min Li quickly stood up from their comfortable seats and bowed to her once they realized who she was.

"Disciple Xuan and Disciple Min? What are you two doing here?" Elder Shan unconsciously asked them.

"We're here to watch them practice," Xuan Wuhan said.

"Oh? But I thought you wouldn't be back at the sect for another week? Did something happen at home?" Elder Shan looked at Xuan Wuhan with raised eyebrows.

"N-No... Nothing happened. I just felt like coming back earlier," Xuan Wuhan said with a somewhat stiff smile on her face.

"You? Hahaha... Now that's something I didn't expect to hear from someone renowned for spending more time outside the sect than inside."

Elder Shan laughed for a moment before turning to look at Yuan and speak, "Come with me for a second, Disciple Yuan. I have something for you."

Yuan nodded and followed her into the house.

"Here, this is an enhanced Pill of Concealment. It'll suppress your cultivation for an entire realm."

Yuan nodded and accepted the pill.

"What about the effects of the current pill? What happens if I swallow two pills with similar effects?" Yuan asked her a moment later.

"Right, that's what this pill is for—"

Elder Shan retrieved another pill and showed it to him; it was a clear white pill without any special auras or designs on it.

"This is the Pill of Cleansing. It'll erase all pill effects that are currently affecting your body. As for your second question, it depends on the pill. If you swallow two Pill of Concealment, you might get a stomach ache at worse. However, if you swallow two very powerful pills, your body might explode, so you must be cautious of what you eat and not eat pills carelessly."

"E-Explode? I haven't heard that word in a while..." Yuan mumbled in a dazed voice before looking at the pills in his hand.

[Powerful Pill of Concealment] [Tier 2] [Purity: 77%]

[Effects: Temporarily conceals your cultivation base by an entire realm for 15 days]

[Description: Only works if you are below Spirit Master]

[Pill of Cleansing] [Tier 1] [Purity: 97%]

[Effects: Remove all Tier 3 and below pill effects that are affecting your body]

[Description: Only works if the pills are below Tier 3]

After swallowing the Pill of Cleansing, a notification appeared.

[You have consumed Pill of Cleansing]

[The effects of 'Pill of Concealment' has been removed]

Yuan could feel his aura exploding outwards after consuming the Pill of Cleansing.

However, that aura didn't last very long as Yuan swallowed the Powerful Pill of Concealment a few seconds later, and his peak Spirit Warrior aura lowered until it resembled someone at the peak Spirit Apprentice level.

"Great, it worked perfectly." Elder Shan nodded with a prideful look on her face.

Yuan raised his eyebrows at her and said, "You mean you weren't certain of its effects?"

Elder Shan chuckled and said, "Of course I'm certain— but there is no such thing as a perfect pill— at least I have never seen one before."

"Anyway, let me listen to some of your zither music before I leave. I'm very intrigued by your abilities in music." Elder Shan then said to him.

"Okay." Yuan nodded.

They left the building and returned to the backyard shortly after.

"You're going to be staying here, too?" Xuan Wuhan asked Elder Shan after noticing that she was taking a seat.

"Might as well since I am already here," Elder Shan nodded.

A few moments later, Yuan returned to his seat behind the zither and turned to look at Fei Yuyan, "Should we continue what we've been doing?"

Hearing his words, Fei Yuyan quickly shook her head and said, "I-It's okay. Since my Master has heard of my zither play many times before and she is mostly here for your performance, you can play by yourself."

Yuan didn't think too much of Fei Yuyan's words and nodded.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan began playing one of Fei Yuyan's songs on the zither.

"T-This is..." Elder Shan's eyes immediately widened just a few seconds into Yuan's performance, as she only needed to see Yuan's graceful movements and listen to the first few music notes to recognize his talents.

'He's already on another level compared to Disciple Fei! Did he really just learn the zither not long ago? This is really hard to believe even with his godlike talents. Unless his comprehension ability works on other things besides cultivation techniques, which would be beyond heaven-defying...'

A few minutes later, after finishing his first song, Yuan proceeded onto the second song after a brief pause.

Elder Shan closed her eyes to enjoy the music.

'I have not felt this relaxed in many, many years...' Elder Shan thought to herself as she unconsciously dozed off.

Sometime later, Yuan stopped playing the zither after his fifth song, and to his surprise when he turned to look at Elder Shan, she was completely asleep with a peaceful expression on her face.

"Hmm?"

When the ladies there noticed Yuan's look, they turned to look at Elder Shan as well.

"S-She's asleep?" Fei Yuyan's eyes widened with shock.

"Should we wake her up? I would feel guilty waking up someone with that kind of sleeping face," Xuan Wuhan said.

"Oh? But you don't feel guilty for waking me up last night?" Fei Yuyan glared at her.

"This and that are two different situations." Xuan Wuhan shrugged in a nonchalant manner.

"You little—"

Fei Yuyan raised her voice, accidentally waking Elder Shan.

"Hmm? Did I fall asleep?" Elder Shan rubbed her eyes before recalling that she was not inside her own room.

"Uhhh... I..."

Elder Shan's face immediately blushed, and then she cleared her throat loudly before speaking in an awkward voice, "T-That was a great performance, Disciple Yuan. I haven't felt this relaxed for a long time. Maybe I should visit you again in the future when I'm having trouble sleeping. Anyway, I just remembered that I have some work I need to finish... See you disciples later..."

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Chapter 180 - Do Whatever You Want

After saying her goodbyes, Elder Shan quickly disappeared from the scene with a slightly rosy complexion on her beautiful face.

Once Elder Shan was gone, Fei Yuyan said, "I guess we can stop practice here for today. Good job, Disciple Yuan, and I apologize for sleeping through half of today's practice."

Yuan nodded since it was also about time he logged off for dinner.

Fei Yuyan then turned to look at Xuan Wuhan and Min Li with a slightly cold expression and said to them, "Shows over, you can go home now."

Xuan Wuhan raised her eyebrows, and then she suddenly turned to look at Yuan before asking, "Hey Yuan, do you mind if I stay here for the night?"

"W-What?! What are you trying to achieve here, Disciple Xuan? Why would you want to stay here?" Fei Yuyan was the first to react to Xuan Wuhan's words.

"Why not? I am too tired to walk after sitting here for the entire day. I'd rather just stay here for the night. It's fine, right, Yuan?" Xuan Wuhan asked him again.

Everyone there turned to glare at Yuan with an intensive gaze, but Yuan didn't even budge an eyebrow and nodded calmly, "I don't mind. But you should get permission first like Disciple Fei."

"Right away!"

Xuan Wuhan immediately retrieved her communication jade slip and contacted Elder Xuan, her grandfather.

A few seconds later, Elder Xuan's voice resounded in a casual manner, "What's the matter now?"

"Grandpa, I'm going to stay over at Yuan's house tonight. Can I get your permission real quick?" Xuan Wuhan said.

"..."

Elder Xuan did not immediately respond and remained silent for a good moment until a low mumble finally responded, sounding a little helpless, "Go ahead... Do whatever you want..."

"Thanks, grandpa!"

After deactivating the communication jade slip, Xuan Wuhan looked at Yuan and said with a bright smile on her face, contrary to her 'exhausted' state, and she said, "Well, there you have it! I'll be staying here tonight!"

'T-This little...' Fei Yuyan silently gritted her teeth at Xuan Wuhan's shameless abuse of her background.

Meanwhile, Min Li sighed inwardly, 'If only I didn't live directly next door to him...'

Because she lived so close to him, she wasn't able to use the same excuse as Xuan Wuhan.

Sometime later, Xuan Wuhan went to find a room for the night whilst Fei Yuyan went to clean her body of the sweats she'd accumulated from practice.

If news of Yuan staying in the same building as two top fairies for the night were to spread to the other disciples, there would, without a doubt, be an army of angry people gathered in front of his house on the same day.

Once Fei Yuyan came out of the bathroom, Yuan went to clean himself next.

"I never knew you were such an aggressive woman, Disciple Xuan," Fei Yuyan said to Xuan Wuhan after running into her while walking towards her own room. "How can you act so shamelessly? I wonder what would happen if the disciples knew that one of the Three Graceful Fairies was such a woman."

Hearing her words, Xuan Wuhan pretended to be stupid and said, "I have no idea what you're talking about. I am simply sleeping over at a friend's house. Meanwhile, you're taking advantage of your situation as 'partners'. It wouldn't take you even an hour to get here from your place, yet you'd opted to stay in a man's house even though you barely know him. Perhaps you are actually secretly hoping that something might happen?"

"N-Nonsense! Even if it's just one hour, it adds up! We only have one week before the competition! If I take one hour to come here and another to return home every day, that's at least 14 hours that could've been used towards our practice! And I know Disciple Yuan isn't that type of person so I am not expecting anything!"

"Yeah, yeah. Whatever you say, 'partner who overslept and missed half of today's practice'." Xuan Wuhan said in an obnoxiously sarcastic voice.

"T-That's all your fault! I swear to heaven, Disciple Xuan! Don't push my limit!" Fei Yuyan glared at her with narrowed eyes.

However, before their tension increased any further, Yuan appeared and said with an innocent look on his face, "What's wrong?"

"N-Nothing..." Fei Yuyan immediately smiled and said to him, "Goodnight, Disciple Yuan. I definitely won't repeat the same mistakes tomorrow."

"Goodnight, Yuan. I can't wait to hear more of your music tomorrow," Xuan Wuhan also said to him with a smile on her face, acting like her little fight with Fei Yuyan never happened.

Yuan nodded and said, "Goodnight to both of you."

They all went to their respective rooms shortly after.

While Fei Yuyan immediately went to sleep and Xuan Wuhan stayed up for a few more hours to cultivate, Yuan logged off the game to eat dinner.

After dinner, Yuan spent the rest of the night cultivating until it was morning.

In the morning, Yu Rou cleaned his body and fed him breakfast before going to school while Yuan returned to the game.

"Good morning, Disciple Yuan." Fei Yuyan greeted him in an elegant manner when he appeared in the living room, even casually sipping on tea like she'd been awake for some time.

"Good morning, Disciple Fei," Yuan greeted her. "Did you have enough sleep last night?"

"Yes, I slept soundly since there was no monkey disturbing my sleep," Fei Yuyan responded with a smile that did not fit her words.

"M-Monkey?" Yuan raised his eyebrows, wondering why she would mention monkeys in this situation.

Sometime later, Xuan Wuhan appeared and said, "Oh? Looks like you really woke up properly this time. I was even thinking about knocking on your door if you weren't awake by now."

"..." Fei Yuyan looked at her weirdly, but she decided to ignore Xuan Wuhan ultimately.

A few minutes later, Min Li knocked on the door and said, "You'll also be practicing today, right?"

Yuan nodded and said, "Yeah, do you want to join us today as well?"

"If you don't mind," Min Li nodded, trying her best not to blush.

Thus, they began their third day of practice with only four days left until the zither competition.

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Chapter 181 - Heavenly Melody Academy

"Un— You have improved a lot compared to yesterday's practice, Disciple Fei," Yuan said to her with an approving smile on his face after another day of practice, resembling a lecturer.

"Thank you..." Fei Yuyan said in a slightly dejected voice, unsure of how she should feel about her situation.

On one hand, her zither skills were improving at a rapid rate that she has never experienced before, but on the other hand, she was being taught by a junior disciple who had less experience than her with the zither, putting her 'senior' status to question and even subtly slapping her in the face with his godlike talents.

'It appears that I am the only one who's really benefiting from this practice...' Fei Yuyan sighed inwardly, feeling slightly ashamed of herself.

"At this rate, Yuan might win the entire competition by himself even without needing your help, Disciple Fei," Xuan Wuhan said to her with a smile.

Fei Yuyan wanted to refute Xuan Wuhan's words, but there was nothing she could say, as she also believed that Yuan has the capability to carry her to third place even if her performance turns out to be lacking.

Sometime later, once the practice was over, Min Li returned to her home next door whilst everyone else went to do their own things.

"Don't tell me you're going to stay here again tonight? I thought it was only for last night," Fei Yuyan said to Xuan Wuhan who was casually laying in her bed and had no intention of leaving anytime soon.

"Did I say it was only for a single night? Since I am already here, it shouldn't matter if I stayed here for another day or a couple more days." Xuan Wuhan said in a shameless voice.

Fei Yuyan shook her head and ignored Xuan Wuhan, almost like she was already getting used to her behavior.

The following day, Yuan and Fei Yuyan went to the backyard early in the morning to practice their zithers with Xuan Wuhan as a spectator as well as Min Li, who was ignoring her daily routine and practice just to spend more time around Yuan so she doesn't fall behind these two top beauties who were already ahead of her in terms of relationship and intimacy.

If her family knew about this, they would definitely scold her, but fortunately for her, she was the only one from the Min Family in the Dragon Essence Temple while her siblings were at the other and more powerful elite sects.

Sometime later, their fourth day of practice came to an end.

However, right as everyone there prepared to leave the backyard, a familiar-sounding voice resounded, "Disciple Fei! I'm coming in!"

Elder Shan did not even wait for one of them to open the door and opened the door with her own keys before appearing in front of them a moment later.

"Master? What's the matter? Did something happen?" Fei Yuyan looked at her with a puzzled face, wondering why Elder Shan appeared to be so excited.

"You haven't heard? The judges for the zither competition have been announced and you won't believe who'll be judging this year's competition!" Elder Shan said.

"Who?" Fei Yuyan asked with a slightly dazed look on her face, as she has never seen Elder Shan so excited before.

"The Sect Master of Heavenly Melody Academy— Senior Song Ling'er!" Elder Shan said with a smile on her face.

"WHAT?! SENIOR SONG LING'ER?!" Fei Yuyan exclaimed in a shocked voice, startling Yuan and the other two.

"Senior Song Ling'er? Who's that?" Yuan decided to ask her.

"Y-You don't know Senior Song? The number one zither expert in the Lower Heavens? She's even called the Goddess of Music!"

"Goddess of Music?" Yuan raised his eyebrows, unsure of how to feel about such an overbearing title.

"The Heavenly Melody Academy is an elite sect that purely focuses on instruments with most of if not all of their disciples using instruments as their weapons, and their Sect Master, Senior Song Ling'er, has mastered over a dozen instruments with the zither being her favorite," Elder Shan explained to Yuan.

"Honestly, I wanted to join the Heavenly Melody Academy at first before the Dragon Essence Temple, but I wasn't determined enough to focus on the zither at that time so I went with the Dragon Essence Temple instead." Fei Yuyan shrugged.

"Do you regret it?" Elder Shan suddenly asked her. "You could've definitely become a Core Disciple there as well with your zither skills."

"I would be lying if I say that I don't since there are times when I wonder if I would've done better as a disciple at the Heavenly Melody Academy, but I am mostly glad that I'd joined the Dragon Essence Temple, Master." Fei Yuyan said.

Elder Shan nodded with a smile on her face, and she continued, "Anyway, there will be two more judges alongside Senior Song, but they might as

well not be there with Senior Song's presence there! If you can impress her, it will greatly benefit you and maybe even the Dragon Essence Temple's relationship with the Heavenly Melody Academy."

"Although the Heavenly Melody Academy is vastly different from the other sects, do not underestimate their prowess, as they are ranked the 3rd strongest sect in the Lower Heavens."

"What about our Dragon Essence Temple? Where do we rank?" Yuan suddenly asked.

A bittersweet smile appeared on Elder Shan's face, and she responded, "During our Founder's era, our Dragon Essence Temple was number one, but alas, ever since his disappearance, we have slowly dropped in the ranks, and we're now only 7th in the ranking."

"7th? That's already very good, no?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"Of course, but compared to our former glory, it's quite shameful and a slap to our Ancestors' faces..." Elder Shan sighed.

"Anyway, I believe that our ranking will soon change for the better so it's all good." Elder Shan winked her pretty eyes at Yuan, dumbfounding the three ladies there, and they silently wondered what else Yuan was hiding from them.

Chapter 182 - Practicing Until Morning

Shortly after Elder Shan left the place, Fei Yuyan suddenly said, "Disciple Yuan, you can rest for the day. I am going to practice a little longer."

"Eh?" Yuan looked at her with raised eyebrows, and he said, "You have already practiced for 10 hours today. It's better to get some rest."

"I know, but I don't think I can calm down so quickly after learning about Senior Song. She has countless admirers whether it'd be for her beauty or her musical abilities. I've admired her ever since I can remember," Fei Yuyan said.

And she continued, "Now that I know about her appearance at the competition, I must not embarrass myself at all cost! Therefore, I am going to practice more and try my best to impress her!"

Yuan nodded and said to her, "Don't overdo it, Disciple Fei. It'll be problematic if you tire yourself out right before the competition. It's happened to me multiple times so I know how it feels."

Fei Yuyan smiled and said, "Are you worried about me? Don't forget that I am a Cultivator—a Spirit Warrior. I can practice for an entire week without rest and will still feel perfectly fine."

Sometime later, Yuan and the others left the backyard whilst Fei Yuyan remained to practice her zither.

"Brother, guess what's being talked about in my school!" Yu Rou asked Yuan after she returned home.

"What?"

"The zither competition! You know my school is a prestigious school for musicians— there's no way they wouldn't talk about something as massive as the zither competition!" Yu Rou said.

"In fact, I even know a couple of students in my school who intend on participating in the zither competition!"

"Eh? There are people in your school that also know how to play the zither?" Yuan asked with his interest piqued.

"Yes, a lot of people in my school play Cultivation Online, and they learned to play the zither there. Of course, they are still not very good at it, but they still wanted to participate. As for the others, there'll only be at the competition as a spectator."

Yu Rou then continued, "Therefore, try not to reveal yourself, okay? Most people nowadays may not remember you, but there's a lot of students in my school that still remember your talents, brother, especially since I am there."

"Don't worry, I will be wearing a mask for the competition just in case," Yuan said.

"Good." Yu Rou nodded.

"By the way, I would like to stay in the game tonight and practice the zither some more." Yuan suddenly said.

"Don't overwork yourself, brother. You should know by now that rest is as important as the practice itself."

"I know, Yu Rou. There's no reason for me to overwork myself, anyway."

"Okay..."

A few minutes later, Yuan returned inside the game, and he went to the backyard to see whether Fei Yuyan was still practicing or not.

And as he'd expected, Fei Yuyan, while being basked in gentle moonlight, was practicing the zither.

"What's the matter, Disciple Yuan?" Fei Yuyan stopped playing to look at him. "Couldn't sleep?"

"No, I've just decided to practice some more with you," Yuan said to her.

"Are you sure? You can go ahead and sleep if you want to. I am doing this on my own accord so you don't need to feel guilty about leaving me alone." Fei Yuyan said with a smile on her face.

"I am also here on my own accord so you don't have to worry. The competition is only a couple of days away, and I don't want to disappoint you so I'll try my best until then."

"Disappoint me...?" Fei Yuyan looked at Yuan with a slightly dazed look on her face.

Yuan nodded with a smile and said, "Since you came to me and asked me to become your partner, I feel an obligation to meet your expectations."

Fei Yuyan blushed for some reason after hearing Yuan's words, and she nodded, "Since you insist on practicing with me, there's no reason for me to refuse."

A few moments later, Yuan sat beside her and placed his hands on the zither.

"Then let's practice all night!" Fei Yuyan said, and they began playing the zither together.

"Hmm? This sounds like Disciple Yuan's zither..." Min Li, who had her windows open, could suddenly hear another person playing the zither besides Fei Yuyan.

The thought of closing the windows to sleep in silence was thrown out of Min Li's mind, and she decided to sleep with the zither music in the background.

As for Xuan Wuhan, she was completely oblivious to the situation outside since she didn't have her windows opened, which activates the sound-proofing formation and prevents all sound from entering her room.

Thus, she spent the entire night in her own room whilst Yuan and Fei Yuyan played the zither together until it was morning.

"Wow... It's already morning? It didn't feel like that much time had passed!" Fei Yuyan exclaimed when she saw the sun rising on the horizon.

"Time passes much quicker when we're absorbed, especially when it comes to music. And congratulations, Disciple Fei, you can now perfectly synchronize your music with mine." Yuan said to her with a satisfied smile on his face, feeling incredibly refreshed despite spending all night practicing.

"Did you already forget? You can call me Fei Yuyan when we're alone," she said, also with a smile on her face.

Sometime later, Fei Yuyan went back into the house to clean herself.

Once they were both clean and refreshed, Fei Yuyan asked Yuan, "What do you want to do today? Do you want to continue practicing after a short break?"

Yuan asked, "The competition is only 2 days away, right?"

"The competition doesn't actually start until the third day, but we will take the whole day before the competition to rest and prepare ourselves, so today will be our last day practicing." Fei Yuyan said to him.

"Okay." Yuan nodded, feeling quite excited about the competition.

Chapter 183 - Last Day Of Practice

"I will be right back," Yuan said to Fei Yuyan after taking a shower, as it was about time for him to eat breakfast.

"Okay, I'll see you in a bit."

After returning to his room, Yuan logged off the game and waited for Yu Rou to do her routine.

About an hour later, Yuan logs back into the game to find Fei Yuyan casually sipping tea in the living room.

"Did you already eat breakfast?" Yuan asked her.

"Breakfast? No. I only eat food once a week." Fei Yuyan casually responded.

"Eh?" Yuan looked at her with wide eyes.

"Once a week?! That's unhealthy! Especially if you're spending so much time practicing!" he said to her.

Fei Yuyan raised her eyebrows and said, "What are you talking about? As Cultivators, we don't need to eat as often as mortals since we feed on spiritual energy. In fact, most Cultivators treat food like snacks."

Yuan stared at Fei Yuyan with a loose jaw. Because his breakthroughs mostly relied on monster cores and fortuitous encounters such as the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower, he didn't know that he could fill his stomach with spiritual energy alone.

"Even if you can fill your stomach with spiritual energy... That still sounds unhealthy..." Yuan mumbled, as he cannot even begin to imagine eating no food for an entire week straight.

Furthermore, while spiritual energy may be able to fill up one's stomach, what about one's nutrition? Does spiritual energy have the necessary nutrition for one's body? How is that any different from drinking water to fill up one's stomach?

"If you want to eat something, you can go ahead and eat without me. I can wait for you to return before we start practice." Fei Yuyan said to him.

Yuan shook his head and said, "No, it's fine. I already ate. We can begin to practice whenever you're ready."

Fei Yuyan raised her eyebrows. Did he eat inside his room or something?

After shaking the questions in her mind away, Fei Yuyan tilted her head backward along with the teacup, gulping down the tea at once.

"Okay, let's start practice now." Fei Yuyan said to him afterward.

Yuan nodded, and as he turned to walk outside, Fei Yuyan suddenly said, "We can stay inside today; it's raining outside right now."

"Oh, okay." Yuan nodded again before taking a seat on the couch.

A few minutes later, once they were in position and prepared, the two of them began playing the zither.

Xuan Wuhan woke up an hour later with Min Li knocking on the door a few minutes later.

"Wow, it sounds even more impactful since we're inside a closed area," Xuan Wuhan said with a slightly dazed look on her face after listening to her first song for the day.

"Also, it sounded like you've both improved a lot since yesterday. How much did you actually practice last night? Did you even sleep?" Xuan

Wuhan asked them afterward.

"No, we didn't sleep last night actually. Instead, we'd spent the entire night playing the zither together— alone." Fei Yuyan responded to her in a calm voice.

Xuan Wuhan's eyes widened, and she proceeded to stare at Fei Yuyan with a speechless look on her face.

"Anyway, let's continue." Fei Yuyan said to Yuan, and they continued practicing the zither again.

Time passed quickly and before they realized it, it was already night again.

"Okay, Disciple Yuan. This is enough for today. Go rest now, and then we'll spend the entire day tomorrow resting even more. Our body and mind must be in perfect shape before the competition, after all." Fei Yuyan said to him at the end of their practice session.

"Okay." Yuan nodded and went to shower first this time.

Once Yuan returned, Fei Yuyan went to clean herself.

"What do you think, Yuan? Are you confident in your abilities? Do you think you'll have a chance at 3rd place? I don't know much about zither, but if someone like Disciple Fei could reach 7th place, you'll definitely be able to reach 3rd place if not even first place!" Xuan Wuhan said to him.

"I am also unsure about my current standing since I am new to the zither and Disciple Fei is the only other zither player I know and can compare to. However, no matter what happens, I'll play the zither to the best of my abilities and hopefully, meet Disciple Fei's expectations," Yuan said with a smile on his face.

"You're quite the humble one despite your talents, Yuan. I really admire that. You're clearly already better than Disciple Fei who is already highly established and respected in the zither community, yet you act like equals."

"Well, I've learned at a very young age to never look down on others regardless of their situation, so I can only look up to or as equal to somebody," Yuan said.

"Your parents have taught you well then..." Xuan Wuhan said.

However, a bittersweet smile appeared on Yuan's face, and he said in a slightly dispirited voice, "The only thing my parents taught me was music and instruments. Everything else was either self-taught or taught by my sister."

"I-Is that so? Then who taught you to be humble?" Xuan Wuhan asked, feeling a little awkward now.

A weird smile appeared on Yuan's face, and he said, "It took a while, but I learned it after realizing why all of my opponents were crying and staring at me with hatred on their faces after a music competition."

"Although I didn't realize it until it was too late, I had always looked at my opponents with a cold and indifferent face. Perhaps they mistook my natural expression as arrogance, hence why I was hated by a lot of people."

"You? Arrogant and indifferent? I cannot imagine it, especially the being hated part." Xuan Wuhan said.

Yuan chuckled and said, "I don't really remember most of it, but my sister would always tell me how much I have changed compared to my childhood days. Perhaps living most of my life as a cripple had really changed my character."

"Eh? What did you just say? A cripple? You?"

Xuan Wuhan and Min Li stared at Yuan with wide eyes after he accidentally spilled some beans.

Chapter 184 - Two Life

"Ehhh..." Yuan looked at the two beauties with an awkward look on his face after realizing what he'd just said.

"A-Anyway, I am getting very sleepy, so I am going to retire for the day. I'll see you all tomorrow," Yuan said to them before rushing upstairs, almost like he was running away before they could further question him.

"What was that about?"

Xuan Wuhan and Min Li exchanged looks with each other. Yuan was definitely keeping something from them, but who doesn't have a few secrets they'd rather keep to themselves?

"It's getting late so I'll be leaving too. I'll see you tomorrow, Senior apprentice-sister Xuan..." Min Li said as she left the building.

"Guess I'll go cultivate," Xuan Wuhan shrugged before going into her room.

"Hmm? Where did everyone go?" Fei Yuyan came out of the bathroom a few minutes later to see an empty living room.

"Oh well..."

Fei Yuyan shook her head before going into her room and falling asleep shortly later.

The following day, Xuan Wuhan asked everyone there, "What are you going to do today if you're not going to be practicing the zither?"

"Well..."

However, before Fei Yuyan could respond, someone knocked on the door before a voice resounded, "Are you guys inside? It's me!"

"Master?" Fei Yuyan went to open the door after hearing Elder Shan's voice.

"What's the matter, Master?" Fei Yuyan asked after greeting her.

"What do you mean? The tournament's tomorrow, you know, and I'm here to see if you're ready to leave yet."

"We're leaving the sect already? I thought we wouldn't have to depart until tomorrow morning." Fei Yuyan said with raised eyebrows since this did not happen last time.

"Due to the presence of Heaven and Earth Palace and Senior Song, the place will be much more crowded than last time. If we don't leave now, we'll have trouble getting into the city." Elder Shan explained.

"Oh, that makes sense..." Fei Yuyan then turned to look at Yuan and asked him, "Are you ready to leave now?"

Yuan immediately nodded and said, "I am ready to leave whenever you are."

"W-Wait a second! Elder Shan! I would also like to come with you!" Xuan Wuhan suddenly said.

"You?" Elder Shan raised her eyebrows, and then she said, "I can only carry two other individuals on my flying treasure so you'll have to ask your grandfather to take you."

"Eh? My grandpa is also going?" Xuan Wuhan mumbled in a surprised tone.

Elder Shan nodded and said, "Yes, that's why you should talk to him instead."

"Anyway, we need to speak with the Sect Master before we leave the sect. Come with me, Disciple Fei, Disciple Yuan."

"I'll see you two later," Yuan said to Min Li and Xuan Wuhan.

Once Fei Yuyan and Yuan left with Elder Shan, Xuan Wuhan and Min Li looked at each other.

"D-Do you think Grand Elder Xuan would be willing to take me along?" Min Li asked Xuan Wuhan.

"I can ask for you..." Xuan Wuhan nodded.

"Thank you, senior apprentice-sister."

Meanwhile, at the Sect Master's headquarters sometime later, Elder Shan knocked on the door and said, "Sect Master, I've brought Disciple Fei and Disciple Yuan here, and we'll be leaving the sect soon."

"Come inside."

A moment later, they entered the room.

"I didn't think I'd see you again so soon, Disciple Yuan." Long Yijun said with a somewhat stiff smile on his face.

"Anyway, about this zither competition... There'll be a lot of people there, you know?"

"I know," Yuan nodded.

"If there's a lot of people, it means there'll be a lot of people watching you..." Long Yijun narrowed his eyes at Yuan, who appeared oblivious at this moment.

Yuan suddenly smiled and said, "Don't worry, Sect Master, I'll be wearing a mask during the competition so that people won't be able to recognize me."

"Oh?" Long Yijun and Elder Shan looked at Yuan with surprised looks on their faces. They didn't think he would be aware, which definitely was a shocker.

Sometime later, Long Yijun retrieved a medium-sized wooden box and placed it on the table.

"Take these, Disciple Yuan. In case anything happens, these treasures will keep your life safe."

After opening the wooden box, Yuan could see two items sitting inside.

One of these two items was a deep green jade slip with the other being a silver talisman.

"The jade slip is called 'Jade Barrier', and the token is named 'Ten Thousand Miles Talisman'." Long Yijun said, and he proceeded to explain their usages, "If you pour some of your spiritual energy into the Jade Barrier, it will create a very powerful defensive formation around you that can block even a Spirit Grandmaster's strike, but it will only be able to block a single hit no matter who attacks you so you must use it wisely."

"As for the Ten Thousand Miles Talisman, as long as you activate it with your spiritual energy, it will immediately teleport you ten thousand miles from your location. However, it does so randomly so there are some risks involved, such as being teleported in the middle of an ocean or in the middle of a beast's nest."

"Remember, Disciple Yuan, that you can only use these treasures once before they lose their powers." Long Yijun warned him.

"I understand," Yuan nodded before accepting these two life-saving treasures.

"Thank you," he said afterward.

'The Sect Master personally handed Disciple Yuan two powerful life-saving treasures?! For what?! Leaving the sect?! Just what is his background?!' Fei

Yuyan cried inwardly after seeing this.

"Good luck, Disciple Fei and Disciple Yuan. Go and make the sect and our ancestors proud." Long Yijun said to them before looking at Elder Shan and continuing, "I'll leave them in Elder Xuan's and your care, Elder Shan."

"Rest assured, Sect Master. I won't let either of them come to any harm, and I'll prioritize their lives over mine," Elder Shan nodded with a serious look on her face.

'What the heck? We're only going to participate in a zither competition, and it's not as if we're hunting powerful magical beasts...' Fei Yuyan was left speechless by their serious conversation, as it sounded like they were going somewhere dangerous.

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Chapter 185 - Special Treatment

Yuan left the Sect Master's headquarters with the others shortly after Long Yijun gave him the life-saving treasures.

"Disciple Yuan," Elder Shan suddenly called out to him, and then she reached into her spatial ring before pulling out a red pill and handing it to him.

"Although this pill is not as powerful as the life-saving treasures the Sect Master gave you, this Pill of Dominance will enhance your combat capabilities by 100% for ten minutes. However, you'll become a bit sore and feel weak afterward so if you cannot defeat your opponents in 10 minutes, use the Ten Thousand Miles Talisman to get as far away as possible."

"Thank you, Senior Shan..." Yuan accepted the pill.

[Pill of Dominance] [Tier 3] [Purity: 88%]

[Effects: Enhances all of your stats by 100% for 10 minutes followed by a 75% deduction in all stats for 24 hours]

[Description: Only consume if you are a Cultivator!]

'Even Master gave Disciple Yuan something to keep him safe?' Fei Yuyan stared at him with a slightly dazed look on her face.

"Let's go meet up with Elder Xuan now." Elder Shan said before bringing them to his living quarters.

"Hmm?" Elder Shan raised her eyebrows when she noticed two familiar-looking faces standing beside Elder Xuan.

Of course, it was Xuan Wuhan and Min Li. In the end, Xuan Wuhan managed to persuade Elder Xuan to bring her and Min Li along to the competition.

"Are we all ready to leave?" Elder Xuan asked them after they gathered.

"Yes, and we just came from seeing the Sect Master. We're ready to leave at any time." Elder Shan nodded.

"Good. Then we shall depart right away. However, before we leave, allow me to give this to you, Disciple Yuan..." Elder Xuan said as he retrieved two items and extended them towards Yuan.

"These two items will come in handy if you're ever in trouble. The first item is called 'Thunder Needle'. You can activate it by pouring your spiritual energy inside, and once that happens, it will explode in three seconds, releasing a powerful explosion that's as strong as an all-out attack from a Cultivator at the peak Spirit Master realm, so make sure you throw it before it explodes."

"This second item is called Dragon Marble; it's an extremely rare treasure with very limited quantities since only a dozen of these were found in the Dragon Temple many thousand years ago. There are only two of these treasures left in the sect, and if you activate it with your spiritual energy, it'll transport you back to the Dragon Essence Temple no matter where you are in this world as long as you're within the Lower Heavens. Use it wisely."

'The Dragon Marble?! Grand Elder Xuan is going to give away such a precious life-saving treasure to Disciple Yuan?! Why?!' Fei Yuyan's jaw dropped to the ground when she saw this, as did Xuan Wuhan and Min Li.

They were only going to participate in some music tournament inside a city. The chances of them being in danger were practically none, yet Yuan still received many powerful life-saving treasures as though he was being sent to the battlefield!

'Why are they only giving him life-saving treasures? What about me? What about the rest of us?! Aren't we also leaving the sect? Why does he get such special treatments?!' Fei Yuyan cried inwardly, feeling slightly envious of Yuan, but she didn't dare to complain.

"Thank you, Senior Xuan." Yuan accepted the small silver needle and the golden marble before tossing them into his spatial ring.

"How can you give him something so precious when I only gave him a Pill of Dominance? Now you're making me look bad..." Elder Shan sighed afterward.

"I'm sorry, it wasn't intentional, Elder Shan..." Elder Xuan said with a somewhat stiff smile.

Sometime later, Elder Shan retrieved what appeared to be a wooden boat toy from her spatial ring.

After pouring some of her spiritual energy into the wooden boat, the toy-sized wooden boat suddenly expanded until it was large enough to fit three people, dumbfounding Yuan.

"Get on." Elder Shan said to them as she boarded the wooden boat.

Fei Yuyan entered the boat before taking a seat.

"What are you waiting for, Disciple Yuan? Come over here." Fei Yuyan patted the empty seat beside her with a seemingly innocent look on her face, yet her eyes glanced at Xuan Wuhan for a split second.

Yuan nodded and took a seat beside Fei Yuyan, even feeling something soft pressing the side of his h.i.p.s afterward.

Xuan Wuhan's eyebrows twitched after seeing this, and she definitely did not miss Fei Yuyan's quick glance.

Meanwhile, Elder Xuan also retrieved his flying treasure.

"T-That's a treasure?"

Yuan stared at Elder Xuan's 'flying treasure' with wide eyes, as it looked like a small circular platform made of clouds.

Elder Xuan smiled at Yuan's reaction, and he said, "There are many different types of flying treasures. You can even find ones that resemble and move like magical beasts, but they're not actually real."

Sometime later, Elder Shan and Elder Xuan activated their flying treasures and took flight, soaring towards the clouds in the sky before speeding into the distance at a speed that was vastly superior to flying swords.

"Wow... How expensive are flying treasures?" Yuan asked a few minutes later.

"Flying treasures are very rare in the Lower Heavens so the chances of you buying them are extremely low," Fei Yuyan said.

"Then how were these flying treasures obtained?"

"I obtained mine during a large tournament two hundred years ago," Elder Shan responded.

"As for Elder Xuan, I believe it was given to him by the sect for his meritorious achievements when he was still a mere disciple. Do you also want one?"

Yuan shook his head and said, "No, I just find them really cool, and I still prefer the flying sword."

"There are also flying treasures that resemble swords. In fact, the Sect Master of the Radiance Sword Sect has a flying treasure that's simply an enormous sword." Elder Shan said, causing Yuan to imagine himself soaring in the sky with an enormous sword.

'Maybe I can use the Empyrean Overlord as my flying sword in the future?' Yuan thought to himself.

Chapter 186 - Accidentally Spilling The Beans

After flying for a couple of hours, the flying treasures came to a sudden halt, and Elder Shan said, "We're at the place. However, since we cannot enter the city with flying treasures, we'll have to descend here."

A few moments later, Elder Shan and Elder Xuan descended their flying treasures before storing them away.

Once they were standing on the ground again, Yuan retrieved a black jade mask and wore it on his face, covering his handsome features besides his bright eyes that illuminated with energy and excitement.

"W-Wait a second... That jade mask..."

When Min Li saw this familiar-looking jade mask, she immediately recalled the mysterious figure during the disciple examination.

"Y-You! It was you all along?!" Min Li cried out loud while pointing at Yuan with trembling fingers when she realized the truth.

"Huh?"

Everybody there including Yuan turned to look at Min Li with raised eyebrows and puzzled expressions.

"What are you talking about?" Xuan Wuhan asked her.

"Y-You! Disciple Yuan! You were the masked figure from the disciple examination?! I saw you during the third exam, even taking notice of you because of your powerful aura! I had wondered where you went because I

didn't see you after the examination! So you were right beside me this entire time!" Min Li exclaimed.

"Eh? Yes... I was there when you took fifty steps," Yuan nodded, not even bothering to hide anything. "Is there something wrong?"

"Of course! You emitted the power of someone at the Spirit Warrior realm at that time! How come you're only a Spirit Apprentice now?! In fact, now that I look at your cultivation, it went up by two whole levels since I last checked! How is that even possible?!" Min Li said.

"Huh? What are you talking about? Yuan has always been a Spirit Warrior. He was at fifth level Spirit Warrior even before he'd become a disciple at the Dragon Essence Temple," Xuan Wuhan casually said.

"What?!" Fei Yuyan and Min Li turned to look at Xuan Wuhan with their eyes wide with shock.

How could an Outer Court disciple be at the fifth level Spirit Warrior realm?!

Elder Xuan and Elder Shan looked at each other with a bittersweet smile on their faces, and Elder Xuan said a moment later, "Actually... Disciple Yuan is currently under the effects of a pill known as 'Pill of Concealment' that suppresses his cultivation level by an entire realm, and his real cultivation base is actually peak Spirit Warrior, but keep this a secret, okay? I am only revealing this fact because it's impossible to keep it hidden at this point."

"Peak Spirit Warrior?!?!"

The three fairies turned to look at Yuan with gawking looks on their beautiful faces.

How old was Yuan again? 18 years old? How can someone that young have such an impressive cultivation base? That's something you normally only see in the upper heavens!

Thud.

Min Li suddenly fell to her knees with disbelief on her face.

'I... I have been comparing myself to a Spirit Warrior this entire time? It's no wonder why he was able to destroy the Training Puppet so casually! I've been fooled!' Min Li cried inwardly, feeling as though she'd lived a life of lies this entire time.

'T-This guy... He's even more monstrous than I'd expected! Peak Spirit Warrior at such a young age! He's definitely from one of the Four Ancient Families if not a hidden family that's even more powerful!'

"A-Are you okay?" Yuan asked Min Li in a weird tone after seeing her fall to her knees.

"Yes... I am..." Min Li said a moment later before standing up and patting the dirt off her slightly stained robes.

Sometime later, Elder Shan asked them, "Are we ready to continue?"

"Yes."

They all nodded.

Thus, Elder Shan began leading them towards the city that was less than a mile away.

'Peak Spirit Warrior... He's not only more talented than me in music, but he's also stronger than me in cultivation...' Fei Yuyan stared at Yuan's back from behind with a profound expression on her face, wondering if there were any more secrets from him.

Many minutes later, they arrived before the city walls.

"Wow... There's a lot of people here..." Yuan mumbled in a dazed voice after seeing the sea of people trying to get inside the city.

"Damn, I've underestimated the crowd. I didn't expect there to be so many people here." Elder Shan sucked her teeth after seeing so many people.

Elder Xuan shook his head and said with a smile on his face, "Even though you are mostly shameless at the sect, you can be quite humble and innocent at times, Elder Shan."

"What do you mean by that?" Elder Shan looked at him with one of her eyebrows raised.

Elder Xuan chuckled and said, "Do you really think they're going to make us wait in line like everyone here? Just follow me."

Elder Xuan did not wait for a response and stepped towards the city walls and into the crowd.

"Eh?"

Despite having no eyes behind their back, the people in front of Elder Xuan unconsciously turned around due to Elder Xuan's profound aura that poked their backs with an invisible finger.

"That's a Sect Elder from the esteemed Dragon Essence Temple!"

"Hey! Isn't that Elder Xuan?! Dragon Essence Temple's Grand Elder! What's he doing here?!"

The people there immediately recognized his majestic robes, and not daring to block his path, they quickly made way for him, creating a long and empty path from the back of the line to the front of the line.

"What are you all waiting for? Let's go." Elder Xuan said to the others in a calm voice.

A few seconds later, Yuan and the others followed Elder Xuan through the massive crowd and towards the city entrance with dumbfounded looks on their faces.

"Welcome to our city, Sect Elders and Disciples of the Dragon Essence Temple!" The guards greeted them in a respectful voice once they reached the front.

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Chapter 187 - Splitting The Rooms

"Don't mind us too much. We're only here because of the zither competition that'll be held in this city," Elder Xuan said to the guards with a friendly expression.

"Of course. The majority of people coming to the city these past few days are only here for the competition. Are you going to be participating or are you just spectating, Seniors?" The guard then asked.

"My disciples will be participating in the zither competition," Elder Xuan responded.

"I see. Then please accept this. It's a small gift from our city for those that'll be participating in the competition."

The guard suddenly showed them a small golden medallion, and he continued, "If you head to the Royal Blossom Hotel and show them this token, you'll receive rooms to reside until you decide to leave the city—free of charge, of course."

"Oh? That's very generous of this city. I'll be sure to thank the lord of this place when I get the chance," Elder Xuan said with a smile on his face.

"Thank you, Senior!" The guard bowed to him respectfully.

Of course, the city doesn't hand out these tokens to just anybody that decides to participate in the competition like candies and only prestigious or powerful backgrounds like the Dragon Essence Temple would receive them, especially if their Grand Elder is there.

After accepting the golden medallion, Elder Xuan entered the city of the others.

"Did you already reserve a hotel for us, Elder Shan? If you haven't, we can head to the Royal Blossom Hotel for our rooms since it'll be difficult for us to find empty rooms right now." Elder Xuan asked her.

"Of course, I did. I am not incompetent. However, the Royal Blossom Hotel is definitely a much nicer place than the hotel I'd reserved, so we can act as though I didn't reserve us any rooms." Elder Shan said, dumbfounding them.

"V-Very well... Since that's the case, we'll head to the Royal Blossom Hotel instead." Elder Xuan said.

"Then follow me. I am pretty familiar with this city since I've been here a few times," Elder Shan said as she took back the lead from Elder Xuan and began leading the others to the Royal Blossom Hotel.

"Wow! Look at that group of fairies! I have never seen such beautiful women in my life!"

"Damn! I would not ask for anything else in my life if I could have a woman that's even half as pretty as one of them!"

The pedestrians in the city stopped whatever they were doing to stare at Elder Shan and the female disciples with bewitched expressions on their dazed faces after noticing their presence.

"Why don't you try approaching them? Maybe you'll get lucky."

"Are you nuts? Look at their uniforms! They're from the Dragon Essence Temple! And judging by their aura, they're definitely powerful experts! If you don't cherish your life, go ahead and approach them!"

Sometime later, Elder Shan stopped walking in front of this tall and massive building that not only occupied the entire street but was also surrounded by beautiful cherry blossoms.

"Wow... What a beautiful place," Yuan mumbled with a dazed look on his face, feeling mesmerized by the cherry blossoms.

After standing outside for a few moments to admire the beautiful trees, Elder Shan entered the building with the others.

"Welcome to the Royal Blossom Hotel, esteemed guests from the Dragon Essence Temple."

A dozen servants greeted them the moment they entered the building, almost like the hotel was expecting their arrival.

Elder Shan didn't act too surprised about this and showed them the medallion.

"How many rooms do we get with this?" Elder Shan asked them afterward.

One of the workers there immediately responded, "Normally, you will be allowed to have up to five rooms, but due to the upcoming competition that has caused an influx of guests, we are only able to spare two rooms. However, each room can accommodate up to four people. We apologize for the inconvenience."

"You don't need to apologize. We can't complain about something that's given to us for free, after all." Elder Shan said.

She then turned to look at Yuan and the others.

"Let's see... We have six of us but only two rooms— two male and four females. I guess it's obvious how we should split the rooms."

Elder Shan then pointed at the female disciples and said, "The three of you can stay in one room, and I'll stay with Elder Xuan and Disciple Yuan."

"Eh?"

Everybody there stared at Elder Shan with gawking expressions.

"Ahem!" Elder Xuan cleared his throat a moment later and said, "Elder Shan, wouldn't it make more sense if you joined the three female disciples instead of joining us— two men? After all, each room can fit four people."

"Why force four people into a single room when we can share the rooms evenly and have more space? This is a no-brainer." Elder Shan responded in a clear voice, her beautiful face void of even the slightest sign of shame or embarrassment, and she continued, "And I don't mind sharing a room with you two since I'm confident that nothing will happen."

"Are you sure about that? While I am also confident that neither of us will do anything, I cannot say the same for you, Elder Shan." Elder Xuan said with narrowed eyes. "But since you want to share the rooms evenly, my granddaughter can stay in the same room as us."

Elder Shan's eyebrows twitched after hearing Elder Xuan's comeback.

Meanwhile, Xuan Wuhan's heart throbbed with excitement, and she could already imagine sleeping in the same room as Yuan, perhaps even in the same bed!

"Why are you making this so difficult, Elder Xuan? Just let the disciples be together. However, since Disciple Yuan cannot sleep with the others for obvious reasons, he can stay with us, the elders." Elder Shan said after a moment of silence.

Elder Xuan raised his eyebrows and said in a casual voice, "Why not? It's not like this is their first time sleeping in the same place, anyways."

"W-What did you just say?" Elder Shan's eyes immediately widened with shock, and she stared at Elder Xuan with disbelief on her face.

Chapter 188 - Did You Two Already Do 'That' Together?

"What do you mean it's not their first time sleeping together, Elder Xuan?!" Elder Shan suddenly stepped forward aggressively, looking like she wanted to grab Elder Xuan by the collars and shake him violently.

However, Elder Shan resisted her urges and stopped after her first step, yet her gaze still stared daggers at Elder Xuan, almost like she was demanding an answer!

A slight smile appeared on Elder Xuan's as he shook his head, and then he said, "Calm down, Elder Shan. I'll explain."

Thus, in order to calm Elder Shan down, Elder Xuan explained the whole situation regarding Fei Yuyan staying at Yuan's living quarters so they can practice more conveniently.

Elder Shan turned to look at Fei Yuyan with disbelief on her face after hearing the whole story and finally understanding the situation.

"Y-You... Unbelievable! How could you not tell your own Master about this! We're going to have a little talk later— just you and me!" Elder Shan said to her, clearly upset about Fei Yuyan's actions for some reason.

"Yes, Master..." Fei Yuyan responded with a nod before sighing inwardly, 'This is exactly why I didn't want to tell you about staying at Yuan's house...'

"Senior Shan, if you're worried about Disciple Fei breaking the sect rule, rest assure, since we'd received Elder Xuan's permission," Yuan said to

Elder Shan afterward, worried that Disciple Fei might get scolded because of some misunderstanding.

A bittersweet smile appeared on Elder Shan's face after seeing Yuan's innocent face, and she said, "Don't worry, Disciple Yuan, neither of you is in trouble, nor is this about breaking the sect rules."

"I-Is that so?" Yuan nodded, feeling relieved that it wasn't about breaking the sect rules.

"Anyway, I won't allow Disciple Yuan to sleep in the same room with the female disciples while I am here, so he'll be sleeping with us." Elder Shan said in a clear voice with an adamant look on her face.

Elder Xuan shook his head inwardly. Knowing Elder Shan's stubbornness and without any assistance from the other elders, Elder Xuan knew that it was near impossible to change her mind.

"Fine... You can stay with us..." Elder Xuan mumbled in a tired-sounding voice afterward.

"Eh?!" Xuan Wuhan felt her heart drop after hearing this, as it meant that she'll no longer be able to sleep with Yuan in the same room, much less the same bed!

While she wanted to complain, she didn't want to sound desperate, and she was not as shameless as Elder Shan.

Meanwhile, the workers in the hotel stood there with dumbfounded looks on their faces as they witnessed this spectacle that would've done great as a romantic comedy.

"P-Please, allow me to show you the rooms..." One of the servants there said to them after their little show was over.

Sometime later, the servant led them to the fourth floor and showed them the last two rooms in the hallway.

"These will be your rooms, esteemed guests. If you wish to stay even after the competition, there will definitely be more available rooms since those who came for the competition usually leave immediately afterward."

"And here are the keys to your rooms."

Once the servant left the scene, Elder Shan handed one of the two keys to Fei Yuyan and said, "You girls can do whatever you want for the rest of today and tomorrow. Just make sure you're back in the hotel before midnight so we know you're safe."

Immediately after hearing Elder Shan's words, Fei Yuyan looked at Yuan and asked him, "Disciple Yuan, do you want to look at zithers with me? I know this large musical store that not only displays powerful zithers but they also sell them!"

"Really? I want to go." Yuan immediately nodded.

"I'll go as well," Xuan Wuhan said.

"Me too," Min Li also said.

"Wait a second, before you go, let me speak with you real quick, Disciple Fei." Elder Shan suddenly said.

"I'll be right back." Fei Yuyan said to them before following Elder Shan into one of the rooms.

Once they were inside, Elder Shan silently stared at Fei Yuyan with narrowed eyes.

After a few moments of awkward silence that felt like an hour for Fei Yuyan, Elder Shan opened her mouth and spoke in a serious voice, "Did... Did you two already do 'that' together?"

"That?" Fei Yuyan raised her eyebrows with a puzzled look on her face, as she was too nervous to think properly right now.

"Do you really need me to spell it out for you?" Elder Shan shook her head.

And she continued, "I'm talking about 'that'! You lived at his house for almost an entire week, right? Surely, you must've had s.e.x already!"

"S-S-S.e.x?!" Fei Yuyan took a step back from shock, and she stared at Elder Shan with disbelief on her face. How can a beautiful woman like Elder Shan mention such a vulgar word so casually?

"We didn't do anything like that!" Fei Yuyan quickly refuted after coming back to her senses.

"What? You haven't? Really? You're not lying to me, right? There's no way a woman and man at your age would be able to live together without doing anything!" Elder Shan said, doubting her.

"W-What kind of woman do you think I am, Master?! There's no way I would do something like that with someone I'd just met! Furthermore, Disciple Yuan wouldn't lay a hand on me even if I am completely vulnerable! He's too kind and innocent!" Fei Yuyan said.

"Hmph! I don't believe it! All men are beasts by nature! If you let your guard down, they'll immediately try to take advantage of you, and I doubt Yuan is any different! Tempt him enough and he'll reveal his true nature! This is my experience with men after living for over 300 years!" Elder Shan said, clearly having some sort of resentment towards men.

"Master, you make it sound like Disciple Yuan is a bad guy, yet you'd insisted on sleeping in the same room as him and Elder Xuan. That doesn't make any sense!" Fei Yuyan said, leaving Elder Shan speechless for a moment.

Chapter 189 - Instrument Store

After a moment of silence, Elder Shan cleared her throat and said, "While that is true, have you forgotten who I am? As a sect elder, there are risks I must take, and I am very confident that I can protect myself. After all, I have managed to protect myself for over three hundred years in this world dominated by beasts."

Fei Yuyan looked at her with her eyebrows raised, unsure of what to think at this moment.

"A-Anyway, you are lucky that Disciple Yuan is a good kid, or your maiden status would've been revoked during your first night together." Elder Shan then said, before quickly changing the subject.

"By the way, do you have feelings for Disciple Yuan? Do you like him?"

"L-Like him?" Fei Yuyan's jaw dropped slightly. Why does Elder Shan care so much about their relationship? She's usually not such a busybody, and it was almost like she's jealous of them or something.

"While I respect Disciple Yuan, even admire him for his talents, so I definitely like him, but I don't think it's that sort of 'like' Master is thinking about... I think," Fei Yuyan responded after a moment of silence.

"Why do you ask, Master?" Fei Yuyan decided to ask her.

"No reason, really. I was just curious since this is my first time seeing you so close to a man— almost intimately." Elder Shan said.

And she continued, "Since you don't have any serious feelings for him nor did anything really happened between you two, I guess there's no need for

us to continue the conversation any longer. Let's go. You want to go to the music shop, right?"

"You're coming with us, Master?" Fei Yuyan asked her with a surprised look.

"Of course. I have a duty to protect Disciple Yuan. If anything happens to him, the Sect Master will have my head..." Elder Shan said.

"Just who is Disciple Yuan, and why is the sect so protective of him?" Fei Yuyan asked.

However, Elder Shan shook her head and said, "Even if you are my disciple, I am not allowed to tell you. But you're a smart girl, so you'll most likely figure it out without me. And if you can wait a few more weeks, you'll know exactly why the sect treasures Disciple Yuan so much."

"A few more weeks?" Fei Yuyan immediately pondered.

The first thing that appeared in her mind after hearing Elder Shan's words was the Mystic Realm, one of the biggest events occurring in the Lower Heavens this year, and coincidentally, it's only a few weeks away.

"D-Don't tell me... Disciple Yuan... He's going to participate in the Mystic Realm?" Fei Yuyan couldn't help but ask.

Elder Shan merely smiled at Fei Yuyan's guess without replying or confirming it.

'I see... So Disciple Yuan's going to be participating in the Mystic Realm...' Fei Yuyan thought to herself after seeing Elder Shan's smile.

Sometime later, they left the room and regrouped with the others.

"Are we ready to go?" Yuan asked them afterward.

"Yes, let's go."

Fei Yuyan nodded before taking the lead.

Meanwhile, Yuan and the other two ladies followed her.

As for Elder Xuan and Elder Shan, they also followed, but they distanced themselves a little bit more to give the disciples more room, almost like guardians looking over them from behind.

"Are you really trying to start something with Disciple Yuan, or are you only teasing him?" Elder Xuan asked her as they followed the disciples through the street.

"I have no idea what you're talking about." Elder Shan responded in a nonchalant manner.

"I know you dislike men because of your experience with them when you were young, but not every man out there is like that, and Disciple Yuan is certainly one of those people on the likable side. I haven't known him for too long, but I can tell that he's a genuine person just from the few conversations we had with each other."

"I know that. You don't have to tell me." Elder Shan said, still with an unreadable expression on her face.

"Then what is your deal? You dislike men, yet you enjoy seducing them knowing full well it won't result in anything. That's very misleading and confusing, or is this your way of revenge to make up for all of the trouble you'd encountered in the past?" Elder Xuan sighed.

"Perhaps. Perhaps not." Elder Shan mumbled.

Elder Xuan shook his head, but he didn't continue questioning her and left it as it is since it wasn't his business, and as long as it doesn't affect the Dragon Essence Temple, Elder Shan can mislead as many young men as she wants.

Sometime later, they arrive at this large store with gentle music playing somewhere in the background.

"This sounds like a flute..." Yuan mumbled after hearing this sharp and crisp sound.

"Let's go inside." Fei Yuyan said to them as she entered the shop.

"Welcome to our store, Divine Melody! How may I help you today, esteemed guests from the Dragon Essence Temple?" One of the workers there immediately recognized their background and approached them.

"We're only here to look around," said Fei Yuyan.

"I understand. Please take as long as you need. There's a small map over there if you're looking for a specific instrument. If you need anything, just speak to anyone wearing this uniform and they'll be able to assist you."

Once the worker left them alone, Fei Yuyan said, "What do you want to see first, Disciple Yuan?"

"I don't know. I am fine with anything, really." Yuan said.

Fei Yuyan nodded, "Okay, then follow me. I'll just take you around the store."

"Wow... This must be the instrument that's being played right now." Yuan said after they entered a certain room in the store.

"You mean the dizi? They are flutes usually made from bamboo," Fei Yuyan said as they stood before a display case that had a beautiful green flute with ten holes in it.

After spending a few minutes in the dizi session, Fei Yuyan led them into another room that showcased a different instrument that resembled guitars in Yuan's world.

Chapter 190 - Spirit Stones

"What is this instrument called?" Yuan asked after seeing the instrument that resembled a guitar.

"This instrument is called a pipa," Fei Yuyan quickly responded.

'A pipa, huh... I wonder if it functions similar to the guitar...' Yuan wondered to himself as they wandered around the room, admiring the beautifully crafted instruments inside the display case.

After spending a couple of minutes in the pipa room, they went to another room.

"This instrument resembles a violin..." Yuan mumbled after seeing this mallet-shaped instrument with a thin handle, and there was even a bow beside it exactly like a violin.

"I have never heard of a 'violin' but this instrument is called an erhu. You place it on your thighs and use that bow to play the strings." Fei Yuyan briefly explained to him.

"I see..." Yuan nodded.

Sometime later, they left the room with erhu and entered the last room in the building.

"Do you recognize these instruments, Disciple Yuan?" Fei Yuyan asked him in a sarcastic voice inside the room filled with nothing but zithers.

Yuan smiled and played along with her, "I don't know, but they seem very familiar."

"Anyway, look at this zither over here." Fei Yuyan then pointed at the zither in one of the display cases and continued, "This is a Heaven-grade zither made from Ice Jade, a very rare material, and rumor has it that it was once owned by the Zither Goddess. The name of this zither is Eternal Imprisonment."

"Zither Goddess? What kind of person is this Zither Goddess?" Yuan asked, feeling more interested in the individual than the zither.

"The number one zither expert in this world. If the Zither Goddess claims to be the second-best zither player in this world, nobody would dare to claim first. There are even legends of the Zither Goddess creating life and stars with her zither music."

"Creating life with music? I cannot imagine such a thing..." Yuan shook his head.

"That's just a legend, but if the Zither Goddess is real, I'd love to meet someone like her." Fei Yuyan sighed with a longing feeling in her eyes.

"Perhaps Yuan might become the Zither God one day," Xuan Wuhan suddenly said in a joking tone.

"The Zither God?" Fei Yuyan looked at Yuan with a weird expression on her face, mostly because she was trying to imagine Yuan as the Zither God, but alas, she could not put together such an image no matter how much she tried.

"Anyway, let's continue looking around. After we finish seeing these rooms, we can take a look at their store and see if there's anything to buy." Fei Yuyan said.

They returned to looking at zither a moment later while Fei Yuyan gave Yuan brief history lessons on almost all of the zithers there.

If Fei Yuyan changed her disciple uniforms to one of the uniforms in this place, the guests would never realize it.

Sometime later, Fei Yuyan brought them out of the zither room before taking them to this massive courtyard behind the store.

Inside the courtyard, there were about a dozen display cases placed in an orderly fashion, and inside these display cases were instruments with a price tag.

Yuan approached one of these display cases that was showcasing a black-colored dizi.

[Black Sparrow Flute]

[Grade: Earth]

[Quality: High]

[Description: A bamboo flute made of black bamboo found in the Black Sparrow Forest]

[Price: 5,000,000 gold coins or 500 spirit stones]

"F-Five million gold?!" Yuan's jaw dropped slightly after seeing the price tag.

"Wow, it's pretty cheap, especially since it's a high-quality Earth-grade treasure." Fei Yuyan appeared behind Yuan and said.

"This is cheap?" Yuan raised his eyebrows, and he asked a moment later, "By the way, what are spirit stones?"

"Spirit stones are a major cultivation resource for Cultivators, and not only can they be used as currency but a single one of them is worth about 10,000 gold coins. However, people still prefer trading with gold coins since they'd rather use spirit stones to improve their cultivation." Fei Yuyan explained to him.

"I see..." Yuan nodded.

"If this was a zither, I would've probably bought it, but alas... I don't play the dizi..." Fei Yuyan shook her head at the Black Sparrow Flute before walking to the next display case that was showcasing another high-quality Earth-grade treasure— a red-colored pipa with a price tag of 8 million gold coins or 800 spirit stones.

A few minutes later, Fei Yuyan sighed loudly, "How unfortunate. There's not a single zither instrument being sold today. The last time I was here, there were 3 of them being sold!"

"Is this everything to see in this place? Where should we go next? There's still plenty of time." Xuan Wuhan said.

"Who said we're done here? There's still one more place in this store that I want to show you, especially Disciple Yuan." Fei Yuyan said while looking at Yuan with a mysterious smile on her face.

"Come with me!" she said before walking off on her own.

Seeing this, Yuan quickly followed her, and the others followed him.

A couple of minutes later, they arrive at this mysterious and silent place with two guards standing beside this door that emitted an ominous feeling, both of them peak Spirit Warriors.

"Where are we? I don't think we're supposed to be here!" Xuan Wuhan said to Fei Yuyan.

"Of course this is not a place for the public. Only those who'd place top ten in the previous zither competition can come here, and since I'd placed 7th, I am allowed to go inside. However, I can only bring one person along with me, and I'll be bringing Disciple Yuan."

"Eh? That's not fair." Xuan Wuhan immediately complained.

"If you can play the zither even half as decent as Disciple Yuan, I might consider bringing you inside later. Otherwise, it'd be just a waste of my time, and effort," Fei Yuyan shook her head.

"You..." Xuan Wuhan narrowed her eyes at Fei Yuyan, but alas, she couldn't play the zither at all.

Fei Yuyan no longer paid attention to Xuan Wuhan and turned to look at Yuan.

"Follow me," she said to him.

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Chapter 191 - Soul Ensnaring Zither

Sometime later, Yuan followed Fei Yuyan and approached the guards with her.

"Welcome, Fairy Fei." The guards immediately recognized her beautiful appearance.

"It's been a while, you two. I would like to go inside with a friend today," Fei Yuyan said to them.

The guards turned to look at Yuan's masked face, but since he was wearing the Dragon Essence Temple's uniforms, they didn't bother to question his identity.

"I understand. You have an hour instead."

The guards then opened the door until there was just enough room for one of them to walk inside.

Once they were inside, the guards closed the heavy doors shut.

"Do you come here often?" Yuan asked her after they entered this empty but spacious room.

"No, I've only been here three times since the last competition," Fei Yuyan shook her head.

"Anyway, come look at this."

Fei Yuyan suddenly grabbed Yuan's hands and dragged him towards the center of the room where a large white blanket was covering a round table alongside something else.

"What do you think is underneath the blanket?" Fei Yuyan asked him after casually releasing his hand.

Yuan looked at the familiar-looking shape and said, "Is it a zither?"

Fei Yuyan nodded with a smile, "Correct!"

She then removed the blanket and said, "This is the Soul Ensnaring Zither!"

"Soul Ensnaring Zither? What an ominous name..." Yuan mumbled as his gaze examined the black zither that had glistening strings like it was made out of clear crystals!

"What are you talking about? It's a wonderful name! Legend says this zither can trap both human and magical beasts' souls with its music— that is if you can play it!" Fei Yuyan said.

"What do you mean 'if you can play it'?" Yuan asked her.

Fei Yuyan did not immediately answer his question and instead took a seat in front of the zither.

"It'll be easier for me to show you instead of explaining it."

After taking a deep breath, she placed her fingers onto the string and began playing the zither.

However, to Yuan's surprise, the music notes coming from the zither were completely different from what he'd expected, and it sounded somewhat suppressed and muffled, almost like Fei Yuyan was playing the zither underwater or something.

How can a perfect-looking zither play such a weird sound? Even the strings on the zither were shaking normally when moved so such a sound shouldn't

be possible. It didn't make any sense at all, and this is his first time seeing such a thing.

"Do you understand now?" Fei Yuyan stopped playing a few moments later and looked at Yuan.

However, Yuan shook his head and said, "I'm even more confused now. I don't see anything wrong with the zither."

"That's because this zither is 'cursed'," Fei Yuyan said, and she continued, "This zither used to be played by the Zither Goddess before she left it here and left for the upper heavens, and not a single zither expert has been able to play it properly since then."

"What about the other zither that was used by her? Is that one also like this?" Yuan couldn't help but ask.

"No, that one can be played properly. It's just this one that's unwilling to let others play." Fei Yuyan sighed.

"How does that even work, though? Does the zither have a consciousness of its own? Like Soul Weapons."

Fei Yuyan shrugged and said, "Nobody knows, really. This zither is neither a Soul Weapon nor a spiritual treasure; it's like a phenomenon."

"I see..." Yuan mumbled.

"Do you want to try playing it?" Fei Yuyan suddenly asked him.

"Can I really?" Yuan looked at her with wide eyes.

"Of course," Fei Yuyan nodded, and she continued, "The only reason this zither isn't in a display case is because the owner wants people to play it and hopefully actually be able to play it properly."

"Then why not open this place up to the public?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"If not even experts can play it, what makes you think normal people will?"
Fei Yuyan shook her head.

"Anyway, go ahead and try it. Who knows— maybe you're the one the zither has been waiting for."

Fei Yuyan then stood up to let Yuan sit down.

After taking a seat, Yuan stared at the zither in silence without actually playing it.

"Haaaa..."

Taking a deep breath, Yuan slowly raised his hands into the air before placing it onto the zither and playing it.

'So even he cannot play it, huh? Why did I have a feeling that maybe he could?' Fei Yuyan thought to herself as the muffled noises returned.

To Fei Yuyan's surprise, even Yuan was unable to play the zither.

"Hmmm..." Yuan stopped playing after pulling a couple of strings and returned to staring at it in silence.

A few minutes later, Yuan suddenly began playing the zither again, but alas, the results were the same with the music notes sounding muffled and suppressed.

However, Yuan didn't stop playing the zither regardless and continued to play it until he played an entire song.

"There's no point, Disciple Yuan. The zither won't suddenly start working even if you play a dozen songs. Many zither experts have tried the same with some playing even hundreds of songs." Fei Yuyan said to him afterward.

"Let me play a few more songs to be certain," Yuan said, and he quickly returned to playing the cursed zither again.

After playing his second song, Yuan immediately continued onto the third — then the fourth and fifth.

On his sixth song, Yuan suddenly closed his eyes while his fingers continued to move.

Fei Yuyan raised her eyebrows after seeing this.

'How is closing your eyes going to help?' she wondered.

However, unbeknownst to Fei Yuyan, Yuan closed his eyes not because he wanted to try something new.

Instead, just like what happened at the Tablet of Comprehension, Yuan had unconsciously closed his eyes and suddenly found himself in an unfamiliar place!

However, instead of a starry scenery, Yuan was inside a pavilion while surrounded by water, almost like the Dragon Pavilion where he met Fei Yuyan for the first time!

Ting~

Suddenly, a heavenly noise resounded in Yuan's ears, causing him to turn around.

And to his surprise, there was a young lady with otherworldly beauty sitting behind him with the Soul Ensnaring Zither in front of her!

Chapter 192 - Zither Goddess

Ting~ Ting~ Ting~

This unknown beauty continued to play the zither despite Yuan's sudden appearance, and Yuan stood there silently to listen to her music, feeling as though every music note was pulling his heartstrings alongside something he couldn't really pinpoint— his soul.

After an unknown amount of time has passed, the beauty finally stopped playing the music before placing her hands on her lap and turning to look at Yuan with her beautiful eyes that resembled jewels.

"What do you think of my music?" she suddenly asked him, her clear voice sounding as beautiful as the zither music if not even more pleasant sounding.

Yuan snapped out of his daze after hearing her words, and he quickly uttered in a dazed voice, "It... It's wonderful... I have never heard of anything like your music before, nor could I have imagined that music would be able to reach such a level."

If someone like this beauty had existed in his world, it would've definitely made his professional life more exciting, and the musical world would've also been much more lively.

The beauty smiled at his words, and then she spoke, "Do you know why you're here?"

Yuan quickly shook his head.

"Because you have the potential to play music at the same level as me if not even better," she said.

"The Soul Ensnaring Zither... I have treated this instrument as though it was my own baby ever since I received it as a birthday present from my parents who'd unfortunately passed away shortly later."

"Then you're... You're the Zither Goddess?" Yuan asked her with slightly wide eyes.

"The Zither Goddess, huh? I guess you can call me that since that's what everybody addresses me as— not that I'd asked for such a nickname."

"If you don't mind me asking, why did you decide to leave behind the Soul Ensnaring Zither? I don't know how long it has been since you left the Lower Heavens but I could still clearly sense a lonely feeling from the zither when I saw it." Yuan couldn't help but ask.

"It's important to you, right? Why would you leave something so precious and with so much memory behind?"

The Zither Goddess turned to look at the black zither in silence before speaking a moment later, "Because I wanted to quit playing the zither."

"Eh? Quit the zither? Why?" Yuan looked at her with wide eyes filled with surprise, as he didn't expect such an answer from her.

However, the Zither Goddess did not respond to his question. Instead, she asked him, "Do you want to play this zither?"

"I... I do... But no matter how much I tried, I just couldn't get the sound out properly," he said.

Hearing his words, the Zither Goddess moved slightly to the side and said, "Come, sit here. I'll teach you how to play this zither."

"R-Really?" Yuan did not hesitate and quickly went to sit beside her.

The Zither Goddess chuckled in a graceful manner before saying, "The Soul Ensnaring Zither is a unique instrument that can only be played with the proper technique, and I will teach you this technique right now."

"Go ahead— try to play it."

Yuan nodded and began playing the zither shortly later.

Tong...

However, the zither still played muffled noises.

"Don't mind it and continue playing it." The Zither Goddess said to him.

Yuan nodded and focused on playing the zither despite showing no signs of progress.

Sometime later, the Zither Goddess suddenly moved, and to Yuan's surprise, she'd placed her fair hands onto his hand without disturbing his movements, almost like their hands had become one, and she began guiding them as though they were her own hands.

A few minutes later, the muffled sound coming from the zither suddenly changed.

Ting...

Although it wasn't as crisp and heavenly-sounding as the sound produced by the Zither Goddess, Yuan had still managed to play a clear sound with the zither!

"You're a quick learner." The Zither Goddess suddenly said to him.

"B-But you're the one controlling my hands..." Yuan said with an awkward smile on his face.

"That's what it may look like from your perspective, but this is actually all your own doing. I am merely teaching you the technique, and you're the one that's learning and comprehending it."

Yuan nodded and continued to concentrate on playing the zither.

In just a few more minutes of practice, Yuan had managed to not only capture the essence of the technique but also incorporate his own techniques into it, creating a whole new technique out of it.

This greatly shocked the Zither Goddess, who did not expect him to learn the zither art so quickly, much less create his own technique off of it!

'This young man is a true music prodigy... If only I had met him while I was still in the Lower Heavens...' she sighed inwardly, feeling profound regret that she couldn't have a rival like Yuan in her era.

Meanwhile, outside Yuan's mind, Fei Yuyan stared at Yuan with her eyes as wide as saucers.

'H-He's playing the zither! He's actually playing the zither!!!' Fei Yuyan cried inwardly as Yuan unconsciously played the zither exactly the same way he was inside his mind, producing heavenly sounds that resembled the Zither Goddess's music.

'How did he do it?! I can't believe it! I want to ask him but I don't dare to disturb him!' Fei Yuyan continued to cry inside her mind, feeling as though her soul was being pulled out of her body by Yuan's heavenly performance.

Sometime later, Yuan suddenly stopped playing the zither, and he turned to look at the heavenly beauty sitting right beside him before asking, "What is the name of this zither art?"

A weird smile appeared on the Zither Goddess's face, and she responded, "My zither art has no name, and since you've made it your own unique technique, you can name it yourself."

After taking a moment to think, Yuan then said with a handsome smile on his face, "Since I learned it from you, I shall call it the Zither Goddess's Ethereal Arts."

Chapter 193 - Zither Goddess's Ethereal Arts

"Zither Goddess's Eternal Art, huh? Are you sure that you want to name it after me?" The Zither Goddess asked him afterward.

Yuan nodded, "I'm sure."

The Zither Goddess smiled, and then she said, "There is nothing left for me to teach you, and I hope you get to meet the real me outside one day. Perhaps you might be able to reignite my passion for the zither once again. Until then, Zither God."

"Eh? What did you just call me?" Yuan's eyes widened with surprise when the Zither Goddess suddenly called him the 'Zither God', but alas, before he could get an answer, the scenery changed, and the young lady with otherworldly beauty disappeared from his sight.

Yuan slowly opened his eyes, and he could still see the Soul Ensnaring Zither before him. However, the Zither Goddess was nowhere to be seen, and he could only see Fei Yuyan's shocked face beside him.

<You have learned 'Zither Goddess's Ethereal Arts'>

<Rank: Unknown>

<Mastery Level: 1>

<Description: A Zither Art created by 'Yuan' after receiving enlightenment from the Zither Goddess>

<Congratulations! You have created your first unique skill!>

<You have gained the title 'Novice Technique Creator'>

Meanwhile, two system announcements appeared back to back for the players to see.

<Congratulations! Player Yuan has created a new skill!>

<Congratulations! Player Yuan has become the first Player to create a new skill!>

"What the heck? You can create your own skills in this game?"

The players around the world were baffled by this new discovery. How does one even create their own skill?

"D-Disciple Yuan!" Fei Yuyan suddenly spoke in a loud voice filled with excitement after she snapped out of her daze.

"Y-You did it! You actually managed to play the Soul Ensnaring Zither!"

"Eh?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

He then turned to look at the Soul Ensnaring Zither for a moment before reaching for one of the strings.

Ting~

A heavenly sound echoed in the small room after Yuan pulled the string with the Zither Goddess's Ethereal Arts in mind.

"How did you do it?! What's the secret to playing this zither?! I also want to try playing it!" Fei Yuyan suddenly approached him with anticipation in her eyes.

"Uhhh... I'm not sure how to explain it... But you need a certain technique to play this zither, and I don't know if I can teach you this technique since even I don't know how it works. If I could teach you, I would definitely do it in a heartbeat!" Yuan said.

"Is that so..." Fei Yuyan sighed in a dejected manner.

A few moments of silence later, she continued, "Anyway, now that we know you can play this zither, we must let the owner of this zither know so he can give you the zither!"

"Wait... I can keep the zither if I can play it?" Yuan said with a dumbfounded look on his face.

"According to the owner of the zither, he will be willing to give the zither to whoever can play it properly. After all, what's the point of keeping something that cannot be played? Might as well give it to someone who can actually use it!" Fei Yuyan said to him.

"Where can we find this person?" Yuan asked, mostly because he also wanted to keep the Soul Ensnaring Zither.

"He's actually in this city. We can make an appointment with him today and meet him tomorrow," Fei Yuyan said.

"Then that's what we shall do." Yuan nodded.

A few moments later, Yuan left the room with Fei Yuyan, leaving the Soul Ensnaring Zither behind.

"Hey, let Senior Zou know that we'll be visiting him tomorrow." Fei Yuyan said to the guards outside.

"Eh?" The guards looked at her with raised eyebrows.

Fei Yuyan then pointed at Yuan and said with a beautiful smile on her face, "We've finally found the person who can play the Soul Ensnaring Zither."

"WHAT?!"

"IS THAT TRUE?!"

Both guards shouted simultaneously.

Fei Yuyan nodded with a prideful expression on her face, acting like she was the one who can play the zither, "That's right!"

"I-I will let Master Zou know about this! Please go see him tomorrow!"

"This is huge news! Master Zou will be exhilarated to hear this!"

Sometime later, Fei Yuyan and Yuan returned to the others' side.

"What happened?" Xuan Wuhan asked them after they returned.

"Nothing much." Fei Yuyan said with a mysterious smile on her face.

She then turned to look at Elder Shan and said, "Master, Yuan and I must visit Senior Zou tomorrow."

"The Zither Master, Senior Zou? Why?" Elder Shan asked with slightly wide eyes.

"Un." Fei Yuyan nodded, "That's right. And it's related to the zither. You'll understand tomorrow, Master."

"You can't tell us now?" Elder Xuan raised his eyebrows.

"It'd ruin the fun!" Fei Yuyan giggled.

"Anyways, we're done here. Let's walk around the city until it's time to retire for the night!"

Elder Xuan and Elder Shan looked at each other with perplexed expressions on their faces, unsure of how they should feel about surprises when it's related to Yuan.

Sometime later, Fei Yuyan and the others began strolling through the city. And because of their prestigious uniforms that were easily recognizable, they encountered little to no trouble at all throughout their entire tour with the exception of a few idiots that couldn't recognize their background and approached the ladies, hoping to gain something from it.

But alas, the only thing these ignorant individuals got was cold and somewhat murderous glares from the three young ladies.

Yuan and the others returned to the Royal Blossom Hotel after walking for a few hours.

Meanwhile, at the Zou Family's household, the two guards from the Divine Melody stood before an old man.

"Are you certain about this information? That someone who can play the Soul Ensnaring Zither has finally appeared?" The old man, Senior Zou, asked for confirmation with a serious frown on his face.

"Although we didn't witness it for ourselves, there's no reason for Fairy Fei Yuyan to lie to us about such a matter," said one of the guards.

"Fei Yuyan... That young lady from the Dragon Essence Temple who placed 7th place last competition, huh?" Senior Zou caressed his long white beard with a profound look on his face.

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Chapter 194 - What Is This Indescribable Feeling?

"Although it was only briefly, I have spoken to the young lady known as Fei Yuyan before. A really talented and respectful girl. I cannot imagine someone like that lying about such a thing. What about the person who can supposedly play the Soul Ensnaring Zither? Do you know anything about his background?" Senior Zou asked the two guards.

"No, Master Zou. That person was wearing a black jade mask so we couldn't identify him. However, he was wearing the Dragon Essence Temple's disciple uniform, so we can only assume that he's a disciple there."

Senior Zou nodded after a moment of silence, and then he said to the two guards, "Bring the Soul Ensnaring Zither here. I'll see for myself whether this mysterious individual can really play the zither once owned by the Zither Goddess!"

Meanwhile, at the Royal Blossom Hotel, Elder Shan said to the three female disciples, "We'll see you all tomorrow morning."

The female disciples stood outside their own room with reluctant expressions on their faces, clearly unhappy about how the room had been split.

However, Elder Shan ignored them and said to Yuan, "Let's go to our room."

After opening the door, Elder Shan grabbed Yuan's hand and forcefully pulled him into the room.

"G-Grandpa! You must protect Yuan from Elder Shan!" Xuan Wuhan said to Elder Xuan with a serious and nervous look on her face.

A bittersweet smile appeared on Elder Xuan's face as he said, "Don't worry, Elder Shan won't do anything to Disciple Yuan even if I'm not there. She's always like this, but nothing really ever happens. That's just Elder Shan for you."

"Even if you say that, I am not convinced! Just keep an eye on Yuan until tomorrow morning, grandpa!" Xuan Wuhan urged him.

"You don't have to keep repeating it. Sect elders are not allowed to be in a relationship with the disciples, anyway. Therefore, you can rest assured and go to sleep." Elder Xuan said.

"If you say so..."

Xuan Wuhan and the other two girls went into their room sometime later whilst Elder Xuan entered his own room.

"Elder Shan is so shameless! How can she act so s.l.u.tty before a disciple if she doesn't intend on doing anything?!" Xuan Wuhan complained out loud the moment their door closed shut.

"Although my Master has her own flaws, don't you dare address her with such a vulgar word, Disciple Xuan!" Fei Yuyan immediately frowned, feeling an obligation to protect Elder Shan's image as her disciple.

Min Li shook her head at them, and she proceeded to enter one of the two available beds to sleep, completely ignoring the other two while they continued to argue with each other.

Meanwhile, in the other room, Elder Shan said to Yuan, "You will be sleeping in the same bed with me tonight, Disciple Yuan."

Yuan looked at the alluring smile on Elder Shan's face with raised eyebrows.

And then he said, "It's fine, Senior Shan. You can keep the bed to yourself. I won't be needing a bed, anyway."

"What? Then where are you going to sleep? The floor? We cannot have that." Elder Shan said.

"There's a second bed in this room, you know?" Elder Xuan said to Elder Shan after shutting the door.

Yuan then said, "No, that's not it. I will be logged off, so I don't need any bed."

"Logged... off?" Elder Shan looked at Yuan with her slender eyebrows raised in a puzzled manner, as this is her first time hearing of such a term.

"Yes, that's why you can keep the bed to yourself. Anyway, it's time for dinner. I'll be back in the morning. Goodnight, Seniors."

After saying that, Yuan logged off the game, disappearing from their sights.

"W-What the? Where did he go?" Elder Shan mumbled in a dazed voice.

Even Elder Xuan was baffled by Yuan's sudden disappearance.

However, before they could think too much about the situation, like some kind of phenomenon, both Elder Xuan and Elder Shan suddenly stopped caring about the matter.

"I'm going to cultivate. If you even dare to try anything funny, I'll make you regret it." Elder Shan said to Elder Xuan as she sat on the bed in the lotus position and closed her eyes.

Elder Xuan shook his head and said, "My wife may be dead but my loyalty for her remains unwavering. I would never do anything to betray her in heaven."

He then sat on the bed in the opposite direction and also closed his eyes to cultivate.

"..."

Elder Shan did not say anything and remained silent.

Meanwhile, after dinner was served, Yuan cleared his mind before he began to cultivate.

However, to his surprise, he was unable to clear his mind, as the sound of the Zither Goddess's music lingered inside his head.

'Zither Goddess...'

For some reason, Yuan could feel his heart beating faster when he recalled Zither Goddess's flawless appearance, who was, without doubt, one of the most beautiful women he has ever seen in his life with the mysterious beauty during his character evaluation being another flawless beauty.

However, even though the beauty during the character evaluation was very beautiful, Yuan didn't feel any different after meeting her, unlike the Zither Goddess, who would cause his heart to flutter whenever the image of her face appears inside his mind.

'What... is this indescribable feeling?' Yuan couldn't help but feel a little worried, wondering if there was something wrong with his body, or even worse, his heart.

'I cannot cultivate while my mind is like this— I should get some sleep.' Yuan sighed inwardly before giving up cultivation for the night.

Of course, it was still difficult for Yuan to fall asleep, as Zither Goddess's beautiful face and gentle smile would remain in his head and refuse to leave for pretty much half of the night.

And even when Yuan managed to fall asleep after much difficulty, Zither Goddess would still show up in his dream to play the zither with him until he was woken up by Yu Rou for breakfast.

Chapter 195 - Qi Manifestation

'What a weird dream...' Yuan thought to himself after waking up.

However, for some reason, he felt a little bit sad that he'd woken up, almost like he wanted to continue dreaming and playing the zither with Zither Goddess.

'I wonder if I'll be able to play the zither with the real person if I go to the upper heavens...' Yuan sighed inwardly, feeling a strong desire to meet Zither Goddess.

After breakfast, Yu Rou said, "Brother, the zither competition is tomorrow, right?"

"Yes, that's right."

"Are you making your way to the location yet?"

"I am already there. We arrived yesterday."

"I see... By the way, I need some help getting out of the city. I haven't logged in since we last played together, but my permit will have long expired when I log in next time, and I don't want to be punished for staying longer than I was permitted." Yu Rou said.

"Oh, right... I had forgotten about that..." Yuan mumbled.

And then he said, "Don't worry, I'll send Fei Fei over to help you when you decide to log in."

"Okay! Thank you!"

Sometime later, Yuan returned to the game.

"Welcome back, Disciple Yuan." Elder Shan opened her eyes the moment she felt Yuan's presence suddenly appear in the room.

"I am back, Senior Shan—"

Right as Yuan opened his mouth, Elder Shan suddenly reached for his arms before pulling him onto the bed.

"S-Senior Shan?!" Yuan spoke in a startled voice when Elder Shan suddenly embraced him on the bed, treating him like some sort of pillow.

"How could you let a beautiful young woman like me stay in the same room as some old man for the entire night? It's like you don't care at all..." Elder Shan sighed out loud.

Elder Xuan's eyebrows twitched at her words, and he said, "I may be older than you, but to call yourself a young woman... That'd make me a middle-aged man, no?"

However, Elder Shan ignored Elder Xuan's words and continued to hug Yuan's body, even wrapping her legs around his legs.

"What do you think, Disciple Yuan? We can stay like this for as long as you'd like... Just give me the word..." Elder Shan said with an alluring smile on her face.

Bonk!

Before Yuan could even respond, Elder Shan felt something hard hit her head.

"Ah! How dare you hit me, Elder Xuan!" Elder Shan shouted in a painful voice before turning to behind her.

However, to her surprise, Elder Xuan was still sitting on the bed and nowhere near her with a puzzled look on his face.

"What do you mean? I never hit you." Elder Xuan said with a dumbfounded look on his face, yet the pain in Elder Shan's expression looked genuine.

"Then who hit me just now?! Are you telling me a ghost did it?!" Elder Shan did not believe Elder Xuan.

"I really don't know what you're talking about, Elder Shan. You're claiming that I'd hit you, but look at my hands— they're empty!" Elder Xuan showed her his hands.

Elder Shan narrowed her eyes at him. It felt like someone had hit her head with something hard and solid, but there was no way Elder Xuan could've hit her from so far away and then hide the weapon so quickly, so what happened just now? Did she imagine being hit? Did she imagine the pain? That's ridiculous no matter how she thought about it!

However, since there was no evidence or explanation to the situation just now, Elder Shan decided to ignore it and returned to focusing on Yuan.

"Well? What do you think, Disciple Yuan? I can teach you a lot of things—"

Bonk!

"Ah!"

After being hit the second time, Elder Shan immediately turned around to look at Elder Xuan, who stared back at her with a gawking look on his face.

Although he didn't see it at first, he definitely saw what happened the second time!

"Qi manifestation!" Elder Xuan mumbled in a shocked voice.

"What did you just say? Qi manifestation?" Elder Shan looked at him with a frown on her face.

Elder Xuan nodded and said, "I witnessed it with my own eyes just now! Someone had manifested their spiritual energy and hit your head with it!"

"What?!" Elder Shan immediately sat up on the bed.

Then she continued, "How is that possible?! Only Cultivators at the level of Spirit Grandmaster can have the ability to manifest their spiritual energy outside their body! Why would someone like that attack me for no reason?!"

Elder Xuan then turned to look at Yuan. Perhaps there was a Spirit Grandmaster somewhere out there protecting Yuan and this expert didn't like what Elder Shan was doing to him?

It was at this moment, unbeknownst to Elder Xuan or Yuan, a young voice suddenly resounded inside Elder Shan's head—

'Stop being so clingy with Brother Yuan...' Xiao Hua's voice resounded, sounding a bit irritated and envious.

"Eh?" Elder Shan turned to look at Yuan with wide eyes.

'Whose voice was that just now? Does Disciple Yuan have a sister at the Spirit Grandmaster level watching over him?! I knew it! He's definitely from a very powerful family!' Elder Shan thought to herself, feeling a little sweaty afterward.

"A-Anyway, let's go see if the other disciples are awake yet..." Elder Shan then said, pretending as though everything was normal.

Elder Xuan watched as Elder Shan disappeared from the room with raised eyebrows, wondering what had happened just now.

He then looked at Yuan, who looked as puzzled.

Sometime later, they followed Elder Shan outside.

"Are you girls awake yet?" Elder Shan knocked on the door.

A few moments later, Min Li opened the door and said, "Good morning, Elder Shan, Elder Xuan, and Disciple Yuan."

"Where's the other two?" Elder Shan asked.

Min Li opened the door to show them inside the room, and both Xuan Wuhan and Fei Yuyan could be seen still sleeping in their bed.

"They spent most of the night 'talking' to each other..." Min Li said with a somewhat bitter smile on her face.

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Chapter 196 - Senior Zou

"Disciple Fei, Disciple Xuan! Wake up!" Elder Shan walked into the room shouting their name, startling them awake.

"M-Master? What are you doing in our room?" Fei Yuyan asked her with a drowsy face, clearly still half asleep.

"It's already morning! Aren't you going to meet with Master Zou today?" Elder Shan reminded her.

Fei Yuyan's eyes widened when she noticed Yuan standing by the door, and she woke up almost instantly, "I-I am sorry! I overslept!"

Fei Yuyan quickly got off the bed with a flushed face, feeling embarrassed to be seen in such a messy appearance by Yuan.

Xuan Wuhan also got off the bed and quickly fixed her appearance.

Sometime later, Elder Shan asked them, "Are you ready?"

"Yes..." Fei Yuyan nodded.

After the ladies fixed their appearances and washed their faces, they began making their way towards the Zou Family's household that took almost two hours of walking.

As they approached the Zou Family, Yuan could hear many people playing the zither, sounding somewhat in tune with each other.

"The Zou Family have zither lectures for those who wish to play the zither," Fei Yuyan said to Yuan after noticing that his interest was piqued.

"Let's go inside."

A few moments later, they arrived at the gates, where a young guard stood.

"We're here to see Senior Zou. We've already notified him in advance that we'll be showing up today," Fei Yuyan said to the guard, who was instantly dazed by her beauty.

"W-W-What is your name?" The guard asked her in a nervous voice.

"Fei Yuyan."

"I-I will be right back!"

The guard turned around and ran away, acting like a shy boy running away from his crush.

A few minutes later, the guard returned with an old man wearing white robes.

"Greetings, Senior Zou." Fei Yuyan clasped her hands and bowed to him respectfully.

"It's been a while, Disciple Fei." Senior Zou nodded his head at her.

He then turned to look at the two elders standing behind her and bowed to them, "Welcome to the Zou Family, fellow Daoists."

"Thank you for seeing us despite being a busy man yourself, Master Zou."

Elder Xuan and Elder Shan returned his bow with their own.

"Of course. I wouldn't miss this chance for the world." Senior Zou said with a smile on his face before he turned to look at Yuan, who was still wearing his black jade mask.

"So you must be the one who can play my Soul Ensnaring Zither, huh? Can I have your name?" Senior Zou asked him.

"You can call me Yuan," he responded.

"I see... Please, follow me. Let's continue this somewhere more private and peaceful." Senior Zou said as he turned around and began walking.

"Soul Ensnaring Zither? Why does this name sound so familiar?" Elder Xuan asked Elder Shan.

"Soul Ensnaring Zither... If I am correct, it used to belong to the Zither Goddess before she ascended from the Lower Heavens, and it is also known as the 'cursed instrument' since nobody could play it ever since she left it behind." Elder Shan explained to him.

"I see... And we're here today because Disciple Yuan can apparently play it?" Elder Xuan mumbled.

"Why am I not even surprised?" Elder Shan said with a smile on her face.

A few minutes later, they arrived at this peaceful courtyard behind the main building.

"Here's the Soul Ensnaring Zither," Senior Zou said as he pointed at the beautiful black zither sitting on a round jade table in the courtyard.

"This instrument has been with my family ever since the Zither Goddess left it behind 25,000 years ago, and it has been waiting for a new owner since then."

He then turned to look at Yuan and continued with a serious expression on his face, "Young man... can you really play the Soul Ensnaring Zither?"

Yuan nodded with a serious face.

Senior Zou did not say anything else and took a step to the side, giving Yuan a clear path to the zither with clear indications.

Seeing this, Yuan walked to the round jade table and took a seat in front of the Soul Ensnaring Zither.

Although it has been less than a day since he last saw the instrument, it felt much longer has passed for Yuan.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan placed his fingers on the zither and closed his eyes, recalling the song played by the Zither Goddess.

Ting~

The strings on the Soul Ensnaring Zither trembled, emitting a heavenly sound that instantly caused Senior Zou's eyes to widen with shock.

'H-He's really playing the zither!' Senior Zou stared at Yuan's fingers and watched his flawless hand movements with a gawking expression.

Very quickly, Senior Zou as well as everyone else that was there became mesmerized by Yuan's zither performance.

'Heavens... It's only been a couple of days since I last heard his zither music and it has already improved by leaps and bounds—to the point where I cannot even compare it to his performance a few days ago!' Elder Shan cried inwardly.

'This is... Disciple Yuan's zither arts? Is there anything he cannot do so perfectly?' Elder Xuan sighed inwardly.

'Disciple Yuan...' Fei Yuyan stared at Yuan with a perplexed expression on her face. Although the black jade mask was blocking Yuan's face, she could still somehow see his handsome face, and the longer she stared at him, the more heated her face felt.

A few minutes later, Yuan stopped playing the zither, and he turned to look at the dazed Senior Zou.

"What do you think?" Yuan decided to ask.

"Do I even need to answer that question...?" A bittersweet smile appeared on Senior Zou's face.

Despite having over 100 years of experience with the zither, he still felt inferior in front of Yuan who appeared to be a very young man. If he knew that Yuan had only been playing the zither for about a week, perhaps he might even be puking out blood right now from shock.

A few moments later, Senior Zou suddenly lowered his head and said to Yuan in a sincere voice, "Thank you... for letting me experience the Soul Ensnaring Zither's brilliance, as I was convinced that I would never get to witness someone playing it properly— at least not in this life."

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Chapter 197 - The Day Before The Zither Competition

"I was told that if someone could play this zither, they would get to keep it. Is that true?" Yuan asked Senior Zou sometime later.

Senior Zou laughed out loud after seeing Yuan's eyes that were filled with anticipation, and he nodded, "Yes, that's right."

Yuan immediately smiled behind the black jade mask.

"However, before I can give it to you, I want to know at least the face of the person I am giving this treasure to." Senior Zou suddenly narrowed his eyes at Yuan, seemingly suspicious of Yuan's identity.

Yuan nodded his head and removed the black jade mask without hesitation.

Senior Zou's eyes widened with surprise after seeing Yuan's handsome and young face.

'He's much younger than I'd expected! A true prodigy! He's a true prodigy!' Senior Zou cried inwardly.

After a moment of silence, Senior Zou nodded and said, "Very well. The Soul Ensnaring Zither is now yours, young man."

Almost instantly after Senior Zou said those words, a couple of notifications appeared in front of Yuan.

<Congratulations! You have completed the hidden quest: Zither Goddess's Abandoned Zither>

<You have been rewarded with: Soul Ensnaring Zither>

<Fame +50>

[Soul Ensnaring Zither]

[Rank: N/A]

[Description: A normal zither that turned into a unique treasure after being played by the Zither Goddess for many years. Neither a normal instrument nor a treasure.]

'So it's really not a treasure...' Yuan was not too surprised since Fei Yuyan had already told him about it beforehand. However, it was still very shocking to know that the Zither Goddess had turned a normal instrument into a treasure just by using it to play music.

"By the way, I have been wondering this, but since you're in this city at this time, do you plan on participating in the zither competition?" Senior Zou suddenly asked him.

Yuan nodded and said, "I am participating in the competition with Disciple Fei as my partner."

"Is that so..." A smile appeared on Senior Zou's face, and he said, "Well, I look forward to your performance. With your talents, I won't expect anything less than 1st place!"

"Really?" Fei Yuyan's eyes flickered with excitement.

After all, Senior Zou has participated in the zither competition many times as a judge, so his judgment is highly regarded. If he says that Yuan could achieve first place, there was a very good chance that it might really happen!

Senior Zou turned to look at Fei Yuyan and responded with a smile, "Of course... That is if you also do your part as his partner. After all, this is a paired competition— not a solo."

Fei Yuyan nodded with a serious look on her face.

"Good. Then I shall see you all again tomorrow— as one of the three judges." Senior Zou said with a smile on his face.

Sometime later, after Yuan and the others left, Senior Zou stared at the sky and mumbled in a low voice, "At last... You have found your long-awaited partner..."

After leaving the Zou Family's household, Yuan asked Fei Yuyan, "What should we do now? The competition isn't until tomorrow."

"Yes, but we still have to register for it." Fei Yuyan said.

"Eh? We still haven't registered?" Yuan looked at her with wide eyes.

Normally, one would register for a competition weeks, even months beforehand.

Fei Yuyan nodded and said, "Let's go to the place where the competition will be held."

Thus, Yuan and the others began following Fei Yuyan around again.

Sometime later, they arrived before this massive and spacious gathering area that could easily fit tens of thousands of people at once.

"Are everyone here participating in the competition?" Yuan mumbled in a dazed voice when he saw the sea of people in this area. Not even the biggest competitions he'd attended before had this many participants.

"Not everyone, but most of them. Since this competition requires a partner, it's only obvious that there would be more people." Fei Yuyan said.

"Come with me."

Yuan nodded and followed her to the large building at the end of the gathering hall.

"Hey, look over there! That's Fairy Fei from the Dragon Essence Temple! Looks like she'll be participating in this year's competition as well!"

"Wow! I still remember her performance at the last competition! I cannot wait to see how much she has improved since then!"

"Who do you think is her partner? Could it be one of those two fairies following behind her?"

The people there quickly took notice of Fei Yuyan's presence, even mistaking Xuan Wuhan and Min Li as her partner for the zither competition since there are way more females who pick up the zither than males.

Meanwhile, Yuan looked around the area and the people there with a serious gaze.

'How many of these people here are players?' he wondered inwardly as he tried to pick out those who appeared to be players.

Very quickly, he noticed a group of people that stood out from the rest of the crowd with their unique hairstyles that easily gave away their identity standing not far away.

'They must be players...' Yuan thought to himself.

A few moments later, Yuan noticed a couple more individuals there that were very likely players.

'Wow, there's a lot more players here than I'd expected...' Yuan swallowed nervously when he realized just how many players were there.

While he feels perfectly fine being around NPCs, he would, for some reason, become nervous when there are players around.

"We've arrived at the registration area," Fei Yuyan said to them after entering the building.

A few moments later, once they spotted an empty desk, they approached the worker behind the desk to register.

"We are from the Dragon Essence Temple, and I would like to register for the competition with my partner here." Fei Yuyan said to the worker behind the desk.

"Hm? Oh! Fairy Fei! Welcome back! I was beginning to wonder if you'll skip participating in this year's competition!" The worker easily recognized Fei Yuyan's pretty face and continued, "Give me a moment, I'll register your names right now."

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Chapter 198 - Replica

"Who is your partner, Fairy Fei?" The worker asked her.

Fei Yuyan pointed at Yuan who was still wearing his black jade mask and said, "My partner is a fellow disciple, Yuan."

The worker turned to look at Yuan with raised eyebrows.

'Her partner's a man? What a lucky bastard,' The worker cursed at Yuan inwardly, feeling envious.

After writing their names in a logbook, the worker handed them two tokens, both with the number 5163 carved into them.

"These tokens will indicate that you're partners, and your scores will be added at the end."

When Yuan accepted the token, a notification appeared before him.

<You are now participating in 'Heaven and Earth Zither Competition'>

<Special event: Reach top 3 to receive special rewards>

'Top three, huh? Since I am already trying to achieve third place, this is perfect.' Yuan smiled inwardly after seeing the notification, wondering what the game will give him for reaching the top 3.

"Now that we're registered for the competition, we only need to wait for it to start. What do you want to do until then?" Fei Yuyan asked Yuan afterward.

"I would like to go somewhere where I can play the Soul Ensnaring Zither," Yuan responded after pondering for a moment.

"You want to play the zither? What about resting before the competition?" Fei Yuyan looked at him with raised eyebrows.

"I can't help it. My hands have been itching to play the zither ever since I received the Soul Ensnaring Zither!" Yuan sighed.

"What are you? An addict?" Fei Yuyan shook her head with a hopeless smile on her face.

"Anyway, if you want to play the zither, I know a place, and you can even have an audience there."

"Really? Let's go." Yuan quickly agreed.

Thus, Fei Yuyan left the gathering area before taking Yuan and the others to this large park in the middle of the city.

However, there were already people playing music in the park. In fact, there were many different instruments being played at the same time, almost like they were competing with each other.

"What's going on here? Why are there so many people playing instruments here? And wouldn't it be rude to play when there's already somebody else playing?" Yuan asked Fei Yuyan.

"Normally that'd be the case, but this place is a little special. Musicians come here to receive recognition, and it's almost like a competition for the people here to see who has the most audience."

"What do you get for doing such a thing, anyway?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"Well, it's also considered training for many people since your concentration can be easily disturbed in this chaotic atmosphere with so many people playing at once. Getting recognition is just a bonus."

"I see..." Yuan nodded.

"Just find an empty spot and try it. You might be surprised by how difficult it is to play in this place."

A few moments later, Yuan took a seat before this stone table and retrieved the Soul Ensnaring Zither from his spatial ring.

After placing it down on the stone table, Yuan took a deep breath to calm his mind and took a long minute to get used to the loud atmosphere.

Meanwhile, Fei Yuyan and the others took a seat nearby, patiently waiting for Yuan to start with anticipation on their faces.

'This is nothing new for me. I have been trained to ignore my surroundings and focus solely on the instrument, even playing through a massive earthquake one time...' Yuan thought to himself.

A few moments later, almost like there was a filter inside his mind, Yuan isolated the surrounding noises, and the only sound he could hear was his own breathing and the sound of his heart beating.

Ting~

Yuan began playing the zither a moment later, instantly filling the park with heavenly zither music.

When the others in this park heard this divine noise, they immediately began trying to locate where it was coming from.

"Who is playing this zither music?! I have never heard anything this beautiful-sounding before!"

"This... sounds too good to be true..."

"I must see for myself who is producing such magical notes even if it's the last thing I do in this life!"

Very quickly, everybody in the park began approaching Yuan's location, and even the other musicians in the park stopped playing their instruments to admire the music.

"Whoever is playing this must be a top expert! I cannot miss this chance to meet a top zither expert!"

Thus, even the other musicians in the park began making their way towards Yuan's location.

A minute after Yuan began playing the zither, over one hundred people were already gathered at his location to watch his performance.

"W-Who is that? The mask is blocking his face so I cannot identify him, but he's definitely a man! I don't know of any male zither experts who can play the zither with such perfection— not even Master Zou! No disrespect to him, of course!"

"L-Look at the instrument he's using! Are my eyes tricking me, or is that the Soul Ensnaring Zither?!"

"What?! The Soul Ensnaring Zither?! That's impossible!"

The audience there quickly took notice of the beautiful zither Yuan was playing from, and they were in disbelief.

"That must be a replica! The Soul Ensnaring Zither cannot be played by anyone else other than the Zither Goddess! It has been like that for thousands of years!"

"Nobody that is currently living in the Lower Heavens has ever heard the Soul Ensnaring Zither's sound before so there's no way for us to tell whether that's the real one or just a fake. However, even without any evidence, I can say with confidence that Soul Ensnaring Zither is fake!"

Although the audience did not believe even for a second that the instrument Yuan was playing was the legendary cursed instrument, they could not

question his zither arts, and they quickly ignored the instrument and returned to focusing on the music.

And while everybody there was too immersed in Yuan's music to care about their surroundings, a tall and slender figure wearing a veil over their head suddenly appeared behind the crowd to watch the performance as well.

'That's definitely the real Soul Ensnaring Zither... But how...? Just who is this person?' The veiled figure wondered, feeling extremely shocked by this abnormal situation they had encountered by mere chance.

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Chapter 199 - Veiled Figure

'His movements... His aura... This person is definitely a top zither expert! And judging by his clothes, he's... an Outer Court disciple from the Dragon Essence Temple?!' The veiled figure was greatly shocked by Yuan's uniform, silently wondering why he didn't join the Heavenly Melody Academy instead.

'With his abilities, he could easily become a Core Disciple at the Heavenly Melody Academy, even a high-ranking sect elder! Yet he decided to join the Dragon Essence Temple that doesn't have any zither experts? What reason could have possibly led him to such a foolish decision?! He's wasting his talents in that place!'

This veiled individual did not believe the Dragon Essence Temple deserved an excellent zither expert like Yuan, even feeling a bit envious of them.

The veiled individual suddenly had the urge to go up to Yuan and tell him to leave the Dragon Essence Temple and join the Heavenly Melody Academy instead. However, when they noticed Elder Xuan and Elder Shan's presence sitting not far away, they quickly tossed out that idea.

'Grand Elder Xuan and Great Elder Shan... What are they doing in this place? Are they following that disciple? Perhaps even protecting him? That's ridiculous...'

The veiled figure has never heard of an Outer Court disciple needing protection from two high-ranking sect elders before until today.

Sometime later, Yuan finished his second song, and the audience immediately exploded with cheers and clapping.

"Play another song!"

"Encore!"

Yuan was slightly startled when he looked up and saw the massive crowd clapping for him.

"Okay, I will play another song," Yuan said to them, increasing the hype.

However, right as he prepared to play the third song, a tall figure wearing a veil on their head and pretty fitted red robes jumped from the back of the crowd and landed a few meters away in front of him.

"W-Who's that?"

The crowd stared at this newcomer with raised eyebrows.

"Damn! Look at that figure! She's definitely a peerless beauty behind that veil!"

"How can you tell that she's a beauty without looking at her face? There's a very high chance she's only perfect below the neck! Why else would she be wearing a veil?"

"Shut up! I know a beauty when I see one even without looking at their faces!"

Meanwhile, Elder Xuan and Elder Shan narrowed their eyes at this unknown threat with great caution, preparing to defend Yuan at any moment. Although they cannot tell exactly this unknown presence's full cultivation, they were sure that she was at least a Spirit Grandmaster.

And while they do not have the ability to fight against a Spirit Grandmaster, they can at least reassure Yuan's safety.

"Can I help you?" Yuan asked the veiled woman who had a flawless body figure after staring at her for a moment.

However, the unknown lady did not respond to Yuan's question and instead took a seat at the stone table directly beside Yuan.

She then retrieved a red zither from her spatial ring and placed it on the table.

This veiled lady then turned to look at Yuan and proceed to stare at him in silence, almost like she was trying to tell him something.

And even though there was a piece of cloth blocking her face, Yuan could somehow see the expression she was making and recognize that she was challenging him.

Yuan nodded and said, "Whenever you're ready."

The veiled lady then lifted her hands and showed him three of her slender fingers.

A second later, she curled one of those fingers, making it two.

Yuan immediately realized that she was doing a countdown and nodded his head.

On the third count, both Yuan and the veiled lady played their zither at the same time.

Ting~

Ting~~

Two beautiful yet very unique and distinct music notes appeared at the same time, almost like they were trying to outdo each other.

The audience expected a chaotic scene. However, to their surprise, they quickly realized that they were able to listen to both songs simultaneously without feeling like the music was interfering with one another.

"H-How is this possible?"

The audience was dumbfounded, feeling like they were existing in two worlds at once. It was an odd phenomenon that they've never experienced before.

"T-This is..." Fei Yuyan's jaw dropped to the ground when she realized what was happening, especially after witnessing the skill being displayed by the veiled lady.

'Although I've never personally heard her play the zither before, there's only one person I can think of that can play so perfectly— Senior Song, Sect Master of the Heavenly Melody Academy! I cannot believe it! She challenged Disciple Yuan with the zither the day before the competition!' Fei Yuyan cried inwardly, her heart beating with excitement.

"Master, I think that's Senior Song..." Fei Yuyan whispered to Elder Shan, who immediately turned to look at her with wide eyes.

"A-Are you sure? What's she doing here? Challenging Disciple Yuan, no less..." Elder Xuan said.

"Who else but Senior Song can produce such heavenly music notes? Eh... Besides Disciple Yuan, of course..." Fei Yuyan said.

"What do you think is going to happen to the competition now?" Xuan Wuhan couldn't help but ask.

"Who knows..." Fei Yuyan shrugged. "Anything can happen at this point once she realizes that Disciple Yuan is a participation in the competition—"

Ting!

An awkward and off-sounding noise suddenly resounded in the area, causing the people to turn to look at the veiled lady who'd suddenly stopped playing the zither.

The veiled lady looked at her own hands that were slightly trembling, seemingly in disbelief that she'd lost the challenge, and then she turned to look at Yuan, who was still playing the zither without a care in the world for his surroundings.

'It took him a single song— No, half a song to snap me out of my concentration... Just who is this zither expert and where on earth did he

come from?' The veiled lady thought to herself, her interest in Yuan peaked, feeling an indescribable feeling in her heart.

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Chapter 200 - Being Poached In Public

Yuan finished his song two minutes after the veiled lady stopped playing her zither, and he turned to look at her with his clear eyes afterward.

"That was very fun. Thank you for playing with me," Yuan said with a smile behind his mask.

"..."

The veiled lady stared at Yuan's bright eyes in silence, seemingly pondering about something, and after a long moment of silence, she finally spoke for the first time in a very soothing voice, "How would you like to join the Heavenly Melody Academy? Whatever position you want, you can have."

"Eh?"

Not only Yuan but everybody there was dumbfounded by the veiled lady's sudden words that turned out to be a recruitment for the Heavenly Melody Academy!

"B-But I am already a disciple at the Dragon Essence Temple..." Yuan responded in a dazed voice.

The veiled lady nodded her head, and she continued in a shameless voice, "I know. You can simply leave them and come to us. After all, you're definitely more suited for the Heavenly Melody Academy where everybody is a musician."

However, before Yuan could even respond, the veiled lady lifted her right hand and grabbed the red veil that was covering her face before pulling it

off her head, revealing the peerless face behind it.

When the people there saw this extremely beautiful woman that resembled a goddess, their eyes and mouths widened with shock.

"T-That's!"

"Senior Song?!"

"What! She was the Sect Master of the Heavenly Melody Academy this entire time?!"

"D-Does this mean that unknown zither expert had managed to defeat Senior Song, who is widely recognized as the Goddess of Music, in a one-on-one zither battle?! This is unprecedented!"

"She really was Senior Song..." Fei Yuyan mumbled in a dazed voice.

After revealing her identity to the people there, Song Ling'er stood up and turned to look at Elder Xuan and Elder Shan with a serious expression on her face.

"I have never done this before— poaching a disciple from another sect and even in front of their sect elders and fellow disciple. What I am doing right now will definitely tarnish my reputation, and I respect the Dragon Essence Temple's reputation, but I simply cannot allow someone so talented with the instrument to waste his time in a place where they don't even teach music. In fact, I am a little frustrated that he'd decided to join your sect and not mine. I hope you can understand my feelings, elders from the Dragon Essence Temple." Song Ling'er said to them.

Elder Xuan and Elder Shan were shocked speechless after listening to Song Ling'er's words. Not even in a million years could they have imagined that there would be a day where the Sect Master of the Heavenly Melody Academy would personally poach one of their disciples and directly in front of them at that.

However, no matter how Song Ling'er felt, even if she threatened them with blades on their neck, there was no way they would give up someone like Yuan. After all, his cultivation talents are equal to his music talents if not even above that!

"I understand your feelings very well, Senior Song, but this is not something we have a say in. If you really want to continue with this conversation, then you must speak with our Sect Master," Elder Xuan said to her, directing all responsibility to Long Yijun, mostly because he didn't want to deal with someone like Song Ling'er, who was known for being stubborn and aggressive.

Song Ling'er frowned. However, if she could poach someone like Yuan, even if she has to travel to the end of the world, it would be worth it one hundred and ten percent!

"It's fine, Senior Song, you don't have to speak with the Sect Master." Yuan suddenly said, and he continued, "While I am grateful and humbled at the same time that you'd invite me to your sect, I don't plan on leaving the Dragon Essence Temple."

"Why?! What's at the Dragon Essence Temple that's keeping you there?!" Song Ling'er suddenly snapped, startling everybody there. "I have never seen someone as talented as you before! You don't belong in a place like the Dragon Essence Temple! You belong to the Heavenly Melody Academy, where you'll be able to really shine! If you join our sect, I can guarantee you that you'll become a world-famous musician whose name will be as prestigious if not even more prestigious than the Zither Goddess!"

Hearing Song Ling'er's words, Yuan couldn't help but show a bittersweet smile.

"There are some matters in the Dragon Essence Temple that I must attend to, therefore I cannot just leave. Furthermore, I don't intend on becoming a world-famous musician, since music is only a hobby of mine and I want to focus on cultivation more."

"What?! Music is only a hobby?! That's such a waste of your heaven-sent talents!" Song Ling'er stared at Yuan with disbelief in her eyes.

How could someone with such tremendous talents not focus on improving that specific talent? She has never seen such foolishness before!

Of course, Song Ling'er was unaware of Yuan's godlike cultivation talents, or else she wouldn't be reacting in such a manner.

"I'm really sorry, but I have decided to never play the instruments seriously ever again since I have already experienced enough of that in my life," Yuan said to her.

"..."

Song Ling'er narrowed her eyes at Yuan, but she didn't say anything else.

A moment later, she took a deep breath and released it.

She then turned around and started walking away from the area.

"This won't be your last time seeing me, nor will I give up on trying to poach you either. I'll be sure to give a visit to the Dragon Essence Temple after this zither competition." Song Ling'er said as she disappeared from the area.

Once Song Ling'er left the scene, Elder Xuan approached Yuan and said to him, "Let's also leave before it gets any more chaotic."

Yuan nodded and left the park with the others shortly later.

Chapter 201 - Warning Her Disciples

After leaving the park, Song Ling'er returned to the hotel she was staying at, but then she suddenly realized something that made her run back to the park.

'I forgot to ask that person for his name! What a blunder!' Song Ling'er cried inwardly when she realized that she'd forgotten to ask for Yuan's name due to her frustration at that moment.

But alas, by the time she returned to the park, Yuan and the others were already long gone!

'Forget it. I'll ask Long Yijun when I visit the Dragon Essence Temple. Even if they try to hide him from me, I have already memorized his figure and hands so I'll recognize him at glance.'

Thinking this, Song Ling'er once again returned to the hotel, but her mind couldn't get rid of Yuan's flawless zither arts, and she proceeded to spend the rest of the day thinking about Yuan's performance, even analyzing it.

'Wait a second... That person was playing the Soul Ensnaring Zither, Daoist Zou's treasure! Maybe he knows this unknown expert's identity.'

After spending an hour in her hotel, Song Ling'er went outside for the third time today, and she went straight to the Zou Family's household, surprising Senior Zou with her unannounced visit.

"S-Senior Song! Welcome to my humble place! How may I help you today?" Senior Zou bowed to her in a respectful manner.

"The Soul Ensnaring Zither... When did you give it away?" Song Ling'er asked him.

"Eh? How'd you know that I'd given away the Soul Ensnaring Zither? I haven't announced anything yet," Senior Zou looked at her with a surprised face.

"Because I saw someone playing with it not long ago," she calmly responded.

"I see... So he's already playing it..." A warm smile appeared on Senior Zou's face, causing Song Ling'er to raise her eyebrows.

Then she asked him, "Just who is that person? I have also tried playing the Soul Ensnaring Zither multiple times, but I never figured out how to play it properly, yet this person did it flawlessly."

Senior Zou shook his head and said, "Believe me when I say this, but I also don't know his background. Besides his face and that he's from the Dragon Essence Temple, I don't know anything else about him."

"Wait... You saw his face? What did he look like?" Song Ling'er suddenly asked, her eyes brimming with curiosity.

"Well... He was a very handsome young man."

"A handsome young man? And you don't recognize him at all? How can such a talented individual be a nobody?" Song Ling'er asked.

Senior Zou shrugged and said, "I have no idea."

Song Ling'er no longer said anything and stood there with a pondering look on her beautiful face.

And almost as though he'd suddenly recalled something, Senior Zou spoke a moment later, "Oh, right. He's also called 'Yuan', and he will be participating in the zither competition with Fei Yuyan as his partner."

"He's what?!" Song Ling'er turned to look at him with a shocked look on her face.

If someone like Yuan participated in the competition, it would no longer become a competition but a one-sided performance instead!

"I-Is there something wrong with that?" Senior Zou asked her.

"..."

"No... If someone like him participates in the competition, there's no doubt that he will become an instant sensation. In fact, if I could, I would give him the first place and end the competition right now."

"You think of him that highly? I have never seen you praising someone to such an extent. Your disciples will cry if they hear that," Senior Zou chuckled.

"They can cry all they want, but if they want to complain, they better prove to me that they're worth praising." Song Ling'er spoke in a nonchalant voice.

"Anyway, I'm going to leave now. Thank you for your time."

Senior Zou nodded and said, "My Zou Family will always have its doors open for you, Senior Song."

Song Ling'er left the Zou Family shortly later.

"Yuan, huh?" Song Ling'er mumbled his name as she traveled in the streets with a veil covering her face, yet her womanly figure still attracted countless gazes.

Sometime later, Song Ling'er arrived at a hotel that was different from the one she was staying at.

"Welcome back, Senior Song!"

The workers there immediately greeted her when they saw her figure.

"Are my disciples here?" she asked the workers behind the reception desk.

"Yes, they are currently inside their room, Senior Song."

Song Ling'er nodded and proceeded to look for her disciples.

"Master!"

Two individuals in their early twenties, a young lady and young man, showed up shortly after Song Ling'er knocked on their doors and greeted her.

"Ai Wan, Wei Kang, I have something important to say," Song Ling'er said to them, and she continued with a serious look on her face, even removing her veil so they could see how serious she was being, "This zither competition... You will meet someone exceptional— someone who will make you doubt your own talents and existence."

Her disciples looked at her with a gawking expression, as they could not comprehend why she was telling them such a thing right before the competition.

"I am telling you this because I want you to prepare yourselves, since you two have been acting very relaxed, almost like you've already won the competition. Don't get complacent because you are my disciples."

"We were wrong to look down on others just because we're your disciples, Master." The disciples lowered their heads, apologizing for being complacent.

Song Ling'er nodded her head and left shortly later, returning to her own hotel.

"What happened to the Master? She's acting a little suspicious."

The two disciples looked at each other with a dumbfounded look after she left.

"Master usually carries this confident and slightly arrogant aura around her, but I couldn't feel that from her just now..." Wei Kang, the male disciple mumbled.

"Perhaps something really happened. I have never seen her act like this before." Ai Wan sighed.

And she continued, "She said there'll be someone 'exceptional' in the competition, right? Did she just praise someone? I don't think I have ever seen her praise anyone before— not even her own disciples."

"I'm actually feeling a little excited about this competition now." Wei Kang said with a slight smile on his face.

"Me, too."

Chapter 202 - Introducing The Judges

After returning to the Royal Blossom Hotel, Elder Shan sighed while looking at Yuan, "I knew you'd attract Sect Master Song's attention at the competition with your talents, but I didn't think we'd encounter her before the competition, and she'd even gone as far as trying to poach you. This is going to be problematic..."

"Why would it be problematic? I have already refused her invitation to join the Heavenly Melody Academy," Yuan said.

"Just because you'd refused her invitation doesn't mean she'll give up on you, Disciple Yuan. And knowing Senior Song's character, she'll most likely continue trying to poach you until she gets tired of it, which might take a couple of years if not decades..."

"Hopefully the Sect Master can convince Senior Song to give up." Elder Xuan sighed loudly.

"Anyway, you should stay inside the hotel for the rest of the day. It's best to stay lowkey after what happened at the park today since I'm sure that it is already being spread around as we speak."

As Elder Xuan had guessed, the people that witnessed Yuan's performance were already spreading what they witnessed and how an unknown zither expert from the Dragon Essence Temple had defeated the Heavenly Melody Academy's Sect Master, Song Ling'er. Of course, nobody believed this rumor at first, since they would've known about such an expert already if he really existed.

But as more and more people began spreading the news with even some reputable musicians saying the same thing, some people could not help but start believing the rumors to a certain extent.

"Since there's nothing to do until the competition tomorrow, I'll log off for today," Yuan said to the elders before logging off in their room and spending the remainder of the day cultivating in the real world, even advancing a level by the end of the day, reaching 7th level Spirit Apprentice.

The following day, after returning to the game and some preparations, Yuan and the others left the hotel and went to the gathering area again.

"Good luck, both of you. We'll be watching your performance in the spectators' area," Elder Shan said to Yuan and Fei Yuyan once they reached outside the gathering area.

"Good luck, Yuan! I'll be cheering for you!" Xuan Wuhan said to him with a bright smile on her face.

"Good luck, Disciple Yuan..." Min Li said to him, feeling a little awkward, as this is her first time being in such a situation.

"Good luck, and above all, have fun." Elder Xuan said with a smile.

"Thank you all," Yuan said to them before following Fei Yuyan inside the gathering area.

"Hm? There appear to be fewer people here today than before. What happened?" Yuan asked after noticing that the gathering area was much more empty compared to yesterday.

"Only participants are allowed here now, that's why." Fei Yuyan said.
"Anyway, there's still another hour or so until they close the gates and begin the competition. Let's find a place to wait until then."

Yuan nodded and followed Fei Yuyan around until they found an empty spot underneath a tree, where they proceeded to wait.

"Look over there— isn't that Fairy Fei from the Dragon Essence Temple? She's participating in this year's competition as well!"

"Who's her partner, though? And why is that person wearing a mask?"

The other participants there quickly noticed Fei Yuyan's presence, and some of them even decided to approach her with friendly greetings.

"Hello, Fairy Fei. I am Wan Hu from the Wan Family. I just want to let you know that I'd started playing the zither after witnessing your performance in the previous competition, and now I am participating in the competition myself."

"Fairy Fei, do you remember me? I am Du Ruhui, and I was ranked 8th place in the last competition."

Fei Yuyan glanced at these people, and then she said, "Please do not bother me right now, I am trying to concentrate on the competition. If you have the time to chit chat, use that time to prepare yourself for the competition instead."

These people were dumbfounded by Fei Yuyan's cold response, but it was not unexpected, since Fei Yuyan was known for being distant towards others, especially men.

Meanwhile, Yuan surveyed the area, even paying attention to the people that were just entering the place, almost like he was searching for a certain individual.

Of course, he was simply trying to see how many participants there were players.

Time passed quickly, and the gates to the gathering were shut exactly an hour later.

"Welcome to the 100th Zither Competition."

A familiar face suddenly appeared before the participants and said out loud, silencing the place immediately.

"That's Senior Zou..." Yuan mumbled after seeing him.

"My surname is Zou, and I am one of the judges that will be participating in this year's competition," Senior Zou said, and he continued, "Allow me to introduce the other two judges that will be working with me today."

A few seconds later, two figures descended from the sky and landed beside Senior Zou.

One of them was a woman wearing a crimson red dress and a veil over her head, whilst the other judge was a tall handsome man that emitted a powerful aura.

"On my right side, we have Senior Song, Sect Master of the Heavenly Melody Academy." Senior Zou introduced Song Ling'er.

He then pointed to the tall man and said, "On the other side, we have Elder Jing from the Heaven and Earth Palace, our sponsor for this year's competition!"

After introducing the judges, Senior Zou continued, "Normally, we would grade each of you separately until the final event, but as most of you have guessed, we will be doing things slightly different for this year's competition."

While Senior Zou talked about competition, Song Ling'er searched the crowd with her sharp eyes from behind the veil, seemingly trying to look for a certain individual.

'Found him! He's really participating in this competition! Yuan!' Song Ling'er's eyes widened when she saw Yuan with his black jade mask standing beside Fei Yuyan, and she could immediately feel her heart beating slightly faster than just a moment ago for some reason.

Chapter 203 - Always Looking For Talented Individuals

After Senior Zou mumbled about the competition and some of its history, he turned to look at Song Ling'er and spoke, "Senior Song, are we ready to start the competition?"

"..."

However, almost as though she didn't hear him, Song Ling'er did not respond to his question, making Senior Zou repeat his words for a second time.

"Senior Song, are we ready to start the competition?"

"Eh? What did you just say?" Song Ling'er suddenly snapped out of her dazed and turned to look at Senior Zou's dumbfounded face.

"I-I said, we are ready to start the competition whenever you are ready, Senior Song."

Song Ling'er then nodded, "Yes, we can start."

Senior Zou nodded his head, and then he turned to look at the thousands of participants there and said, "Follow me to the arena where you'll perform in front of millions of people."

The participants there swallowed nervously when they heard that there were going to be millions of people.

While they'd expected and prepared themselves for a large crowd, they didn't expect such a massive audience! This must be the influence of the

Heaven and Earth Palace and the Sect Master of the Heavenly Melody Academy, Song Ling'er!

Senior Zou suddenly turned around and walked into the building, and the participants followed him.

A few minutes later, Senior Zou led them through the entire building and into a vast, empty area that spanned for almost an entire mile, with spectators blocking the scenery in every direction due to the sheer amount of people that were present.

However, upon closer inspection, the area wasn't actually empty, and there were thousands of small wooden tables placed around the area in an orderly fashion with a zither resting on top.

Furthermore, each of these zithers looked exactly the same, and none of them looked any different from another. In fact, they were all ordinary zithers.

When the spectators saw these participants coming out of the building, the noises in that area exploded with excitement, causing the air to shake.

"You have five minutes to find a seat, and you must be sitting directly next to your partner. Go." Senior Zou said to them, and the participants scattered like ants to find their seats.

Although it was a bit messy at first, all of the participants were seated before five minutes had passed.

Once everyone was seated, the three judges jumped on top of three tall platforms that were placed directly in front of the participants before taking a seat.

Sitting directly in the middle of the participants was Song Ling'er with Senior Zou on her right side and Elder Jing on her left side.

"Thank you all for coming here today." Senior Zou spoke in a calm voice, yet his voice boomed loudly and rippled throughout the area, sounding as

though he was using an invisible microphone.

"Before we start, allow us to introduce ourselves."

Senior Zou suddenly stood up and introduced himself, "My name is Zou Fujian, and I was only 7 years old when I first touched the zither. It has been exactly 135 years since I've started practicing the zither, yet I still cannot help but become excited when I see a zither in front of me. This is also my 9th time acting as a judge here. That's all."

After his brief introduction, Senior Zou returned to his seat whilst the sect elder from the Heaven and Earth Palace stood up and began introducing himself with a proud aura around him, "Surname Jing, and I am a sect elder from the Heaven and Earth Palace for the Inner Court disciples. I will admit that my experience with the zither is not as vast or profound as the other two judges, but I have supervised over 100 disciple examinations for the Heaven and Earth Palace, bringing hundreds of talented disciples to the sect, so I know a thing or two about judging people. That's all."

After Elder Jing sat down, everybody in the area turned to look at the beautiful figure sitting in the middle, their gaze filled with admiration and anticipation.

A moment later, Song Ling'er stood up and removed her veil, revealing to the audience her peerless beauty.

"Heavens! What a divine beauty!"

"As expected of the Divine Zither Fairy! Her beauty knows no boundaries!"

"Hahaha! I didn't come here to watch the zither competition, only to witness for myself whether Senior Fairy Song was as beautiful as people say she is! I can now say for certain that she's the most beautiful woman I have ever seen! This trip was definitely worth it!"

"Aaaaah! Senior Fairy Song! I love you!"

The men and women there showered Song Ling'er with praises regarding her beauty, almost like everyone there were her admirers.

However, Song Ling'er did not pay attention to the noises, and her eyes remained fixed in a certain direction.

Noticing this, Senior Zou followed her gaze and turned to look in the direction she was looking at.

'Why am I not surprised?' A slight smile appeared on his face when Senior Zou saw a distinct figure wearing a jade black mask who was also sitting beside a very pretty young lady.

'She's really obsessed with him, huh? Well, I cannot blame her. After all, she always talked about how she will be the first one to play the Soul Ensnaring Zither after the Zither Goddess... I can imagine the shock that she'd received when someone much younger than her stole that achievement from her.'

A few moments later, once the noises in the area died down, Song Ling'er spoke in a calm voice, "Sect Master of the Heavenly Melody Academy, Song Ling'er. We are always looking for talented individuals in the Dao of Music, especially those who specialize in the zither. Therefore, if you can attain at least the top ten, I will consider accepting you as a disciple in the Heavenly Melody Academy. As for whoever achieves first place... I shall make you my own disciple!"

The crowd gasped in shock when they heard such words from Song Ling'er. She was going to accept a disciple today? This was something nobody there could've expected— not even her own disciples!

Meanwhile, Yuan looked at Song Ling'er's beautiful figure from behind the mask, pondering to himself, 'Why does it feel like she's talking specifically to me?'

Chapter 204 - How Is This Even Fair?

After her explosive announcement, Song Ling'er returned to her seat in a casual manner, almost like it was just another day for her.

Meanwhile, the crowd exploded into another commotion.

"Senior Fairy Song will be accepting another disciple?! But if I remember correctly, she'd mentioned that she won't be accepting any more disciples after accepting her current two disciples six years ago!"

However, not everybody was excited about Song Ling'er's announcement.

"She's really sneaky... I didn't think she would strike back so quickly..." Elder Shan felt her eyebrows twitch upon hearing Song Ling'er's announcement.

"Since she already knows that Disciple Yuan has what it takes to achieve first place if not guaranteed to take first place, she purposefully announced that she'll accept the first place as her disciple to use the crowd to pressure Disciple Yuan into accepting. What a brilliant yet shameless move!" Elder Xuan shook his head, unsure whether to laugh or cry at Song Ling'er's desperate attempt to force Yuan into joining the Heavenly Melody Academy.

"What if Disciple Yuan doesn't actually achieve first place? What then? Will she simply change her mind?" Xuan Wuhan couldn't help but that.

"No, that's not possible. Although there are two other judges there, Senior Song's judgement will easily outweigh their judgement. If she says first

place belongs to Disciple Yuan, he will undoubtedly get first place! Who will dare to refute her judgement? Who has the credentials to challenge her judgement? Nobody!" Elder Xuan explained to her. "Furthermore, with Disciple Yuan's abilities, nobody would find Senior Song's judgement unfair!"

"T-This is really unfair! A scandal! How can someone as prestigious as Senior Song lower herself to such a degree just to recruit Disciple Yuan? I cannot understand this..." Xuan Wuhan sighed.

Elder Xuan and Elder Shan looked at Xuan Wuhan with weird looks. If Xuan Wuhan knew just how talented Yuan was, she would understand Song Ling'er's desperation. In fact, if the roles were reversed, their Sect Master Long Yijun would undoubtedly be doing the same thing as Song Ling'er—doing whatever he could to poach Yuan.

Sometime later, Senior Zou cleared his throat, and he spoke in a clear voice, "Now let's talk about the competition itself."

"There will be three different parts in the competition, and you will be scored from one to ten by each judge. At the end of the competition, whichever team has the most points will be declared first place."

"For the first part, we will have each of you play three music notes— no more, no less. You can play any note you want, but you only have three, so choose wisely."

Senior Zou then pointed to the participants sitting in the first row and said, "We will start from you. You have 30 seconds to prepare, starting now."

The place immediately became silent, and millions of eyes gazed upon this participant who was going first, casting an invisible pressure on this participant who felt like a mountain had suddenly appeared on his shoulders.

The participant's hands trembled as he reached for the zither on the table, and a moment later—

Ting... Ting... Tin—

Three very awkward-sounding music notes echoed in the area, immediately putting frowns on the audiences' faces.

However, none of the audience made any noise or complained, and they silently waited for the judges' verdict.

Senior Zou and Elder Jing turned to look at Song Ling'er, almost like they were waiting for her to give her verdict first, but after seeing that she hadn't moved even after a good moment, they decided to give their verdicts first.

"Zero."

Senior Zou spoke in a cold voice.

"Zero."

Elder Jing followed.

Once the other judges gave their verdict, Song Ling'er finally spoke, and her cold voice resounded clearly in the place, "There's no need for your partner to continue. The two of you may leave the premise, as you are no longer qualified to participate in this competition."

The participant nodded with a flushed face and teary eyes, yet he didn't complain. As for his partner who was staring at him with an enraged expression, he also remained silent.

After bowing to the Song Ling'er and the others, the two of them left the area with a shameful back.

"Next." Senior Zou immediately looked at the next participant.

A few seconds later, three beautiful notes resounded in the area.

"Five." Senior Zou declared.

"Six." Elder Jing followed.

"Two." Song Ling'er said in a nonchalant voice.

"..."

The audience was slightly baffled by Song Ling'er's score that was vastly lower compared to the other two judges. However, they weren't too surprised, since someone like Song Ling'er must have an extremely high standard due to her experience and background.

A few minutes later, over a dozen teams were graded, but Song Ling'er has yet to give anyone above three points.

Half an hour and hundreds of teams later, they finally reached a team that was relatively famous, as they'd ranked in the top 20s individually in the previous competition.

Three music notes later, the two judges looked at Song Ling'er.

However, she remained silent.

A few more seconds later, Senior Zou spoke, "Eight points."

"Eight points from me as well. Great job."

Everyone there turned to look at Song Ling'er and patiently waited for her judgement.

Two seconds later, she opened her mouth and mumbled, "Six points."

"Oh! Someone finally managed to score above three points, even doubling it!"

"Who is that? I don't think I know his name."

"That's Ning Xiang, he placed 11th last competition. It seems like he has practised his butt off since then, and his efforts are showing."

Ten minutes later, another team managed to receive more than 5 points from Song Ling'er. At this point, the audience and participants alike only cared

about Song Ling'er's verdict and barely paid attention to Senior Zou and Elder Jing.

After some time, it was finally Song Ling'er's own disciple turn.

"Look! That's Ai Wan and Wei Kang! Senior Fairy Song's disciple! I didn't know they were going to participate in the competition!" The spectators' immediately recognized them.

"What! How is this even fair?! They'll definitely get first place! This is probably why Senior Fairy Song announced that she was accepting new disciples! Because she knew how difficult it would be to achieve first place with her disciples participating!"

The audience was stumped by their unexpected appearance.

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Chapter 205 - Zero Points

"Wei Kang and Ai Wan? Is this even legal? How can they allow Senior Song's own disciples to join this competition? They'll obviously dominate the entire competition!" Xuan Wuhan complained in a sighing voice, and she continued, "I just hope that they're not better than Yuan."

"I have never heard them play before, but I don't think Disciple Yuan would fall behind them." Elder Shan said, continuing with a smile on her beautiful face, "After all, he defeated their master, Senior Song, in a one-on-one battle."

While the audience talked about Wei Kang and Ai Wan, Song Ling'er spoke first for the first time, "You may begin."

The place instantly turned silent, and everybody there stared at Wei Kang who was the first to go with intensive gazes.

After taking a deep breath, Wei Kang moved his arms in an elegant and precise manner, playing three music notes in quick succession, his aura radiating with confidence and elegance.

Ting~ Ting~ Ting~

Three beautiful music notes that pulled the listeners' heartstrings resounded in the area.

"Aaahh... What beautiful music notes..."

"As expected of Senior Fairy Song's disciple—he's on an entirely different level compared to the other participants..."

"Indeed... Nobody else has managed to cause my heart to tremble in such a manner."

A few moments later, Senior Zou and Elder Jing turned to look at Song Ling'er, giving her the opportunity to go first since they were her disciples.

However, Song Ling'er remained silent, her intentions clear.

Senior Zou and Elder Jing exchanged looks with each other before nodding.

The next moment, Senior Zou spoke with a smile on his face, "That was excellent, Junior Wei. I expected nothing less from one of Senior Song's disciples. Although it was only three mere music notes, I was able to fully grasp your profound understanding of the zither with that brief performance just now. I'll give you ten points."

The crowd cheered with excitement after hearing Senior Zou give out his first perfect score, which was to be expected.

"I agree with Senior Zou. It was only three music notes, but I already want to hear more. Great job." Elder Jing praised Wei Kang.

"Thank you, Seniors." Wei Kang stood up and bowed to them before turning to look at Song Ling'er who has yet to give her judgment.

After a moment of awkward silence, Song Ling'er finally spoke in a nonchalant voice, "Do you remember what I told you about being complacent?"

"I do, Master." Wei Kang nodded, sensing an ominous feeling coming from Song Ling'er's tone.

"Then what was that rubbish just now? I've heard better sounds coming from a pig. What an utter disappointment from you, Wei Kang. Zero points." Song Ling'er said in a cold voice.

"Z-Zero points?"

Everybody there including Wei Kang himself was baffled by Song Ling'er's harsh assessment. How could such a wonderful performance be worth less than the others who were clearly worse, much less zero points?

"Maybe she's being especially harsh on him because of their master and disciple relationship. You see this very often— when the master purposefully degrades their own disciples so they can grow stronger and faster."

While everybody there felt that Wei Kang had deserved much better than zero points, who dared to challenge Song Ling'er's decision? Regarding her own disciple, no less.

After giving Wei Kang her verdict, Song Ling'er turned to look at the pretty young lady sitting beside him, her second disciple, Ai Wan, whose back was filled with cold sweat at this moment.

"Go ahead." Song Ling'er said to her a moment later.

"Yes, Master."

Ai Wan nodded, and she proceeded to take the full 30 seconds of preparation time to calm her mind and focus on the zither before her.

After taking a deep breath, Ai Wan played three music notes in a similar fashion to Wei Kang, yet it produced an entirely different sound, even giving off its unique atmosphere.

The audience could feel their bodies relaxing after hearing these music notes.

"Such a powerful yet peaceful note... How does she create such a wonderful sound?"

"I nearly dozed off after listening to her music notes!"

Sometime later, Senior Zou spoke with a smile on his face, "Wonderful! It's only been half a year since I've last heard you play and you've improved by leaps and bounds since then! A definite 10 points from me!"

"I am speechless, really." Elder Jing spoke next, and he said, "It's also a definite 10 points from me."

Once the two judges finished their assessments, everybody turned to look at Song Ling'er, and Ai Wan swallowed nervously.

After a moment of silence, Song Ling'er said in a calm voice, "I'm glad to see that at least one of my disciples had listened to my words. Nine points."

A bright smile appeared on Ai Wan's face after hearing Song Ling'er's verdict, and she immediately bowed, "Thank you, Master!"

'Che...' Wei Kang sneered inwardly when Ai Wan didn't get scolded like he had been shamed in front of millions of people by their master, feeling incredibly salty.

After Song Ling'er's disciples' turn, the next hundred teams failed to produce anything worthy of praise, as the standard had been raised incredibly high by Ai Wan and Wei Kang despite his score.

In fact, it was so boring that some of the crowds even began to doze off.

Half an hour later, three unexpectedly beautiful music notes resounded in the area, sweeping the audience's drowsiness away in an instant.

"W-Who played those three notes just now?" Someone in the audience asked.

"It was that beautiful young fairy—I think that's Fairy Fei from the Dragon Essence Temple."

"Oh! I know of her! She placed 7th in the last competition!"

"Wow! She is not only a beauty but also an excellent zither expert! I think Senior Fairy Song's disciples finally have a real opponent in this zither competition!"

"Are you sure she only placed 7th? That doesn't seem right! Her three music notes were not any less magnificent than Ai Wan or Wei Kang, who

could easily reach the top 3 if they participated in the competition!"

"I'm sure! I cannot even begin to imagine how much she'd practiced since then for her to reach this level in such a short time!"

The audience was blown away by Fei Yuyan's performance, completely oblivious to the fact that her improvements were due to practicing with Yuan, and it was only for one short week!

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Chapter 206 - Yuans Three Music Notes

Chapter 206 - Yuan's Three Music Notes

Clap *Clap* *Clap*

A few moments after Fei Yuyan played her three music notes, Senior Zou suddenly began clapping his hands, and he spoke in a praising voice, "I don't even know where to begin, Disciple Fei. I have witnessed your performance in the previous competition, and if I had listened to your performance just now while blindfolded, I would have never guessed that it was you playing the zither."

After taking a deep breath, he continued to speak, "If you were to participate in the previous competition in your current condition, I have no doubt that you would be able to achieve first place easily! Ten points from me!"

"Thank you for your praises, Senior Zou." Fei Yuyan stood up and bowed to him.

A few seconds later, Elder Jing said, "While this is my first time seeing you play the zither, I have no qualms claiming that you're as talented as Ai Wan and Wei Kang after listening to those three music notes alone. Ten points from me as well, and I am excited to see what else you have in store for us later."

"Thank you, Elder Jing." Fei Yuyan said to him before turning to look at Song Ling'er, who was staring at her with a profound expression.

After a moment of silence, Song Ling'er spoke, "You... Where did you learn to play the zither?"

"Eh?"

To her surprise, as well as everyone there, Song Ling'er had asked her a question instead of giving her verdict.

"I learned to play the zither by myself as it was only a hobby at first, Senior Song."

Hearing her response, Song Ling'er continued to ask, "How do you usually practice?"

"I don't have any special practice routines, and I only practice by playing the zither normally— a few hours every week. However, I have changed things up very recently by practicing with my partner, who has contributed a lot to my improvements." Fei Yuyan explained.

'This girl... she's managed to reach such a high level of zither arts without a proper master? And she's also from the Dragon Essence Temple? Why are there so many talented musicians at the Dragon Essence Temple when they don't belong there at all?!?!' Song Ling'er cried inwardly after realizing that Fei Yuyan was mostly another genius with talent equal if not even greater than her current disciples, and her envy towards the Dragon Essence Temple increased some more.

After a moment of silence, Song Ling'er finally gave her verdict, "Nine points from me."

"Thank you, Senior Song!" Fei Yuyan bowed to her.

"Wow! She actually received nine points from Senior Fairy Song! Does this mean Senior Fairy Song recognizes Fairy Fei's talents to be similar to her own disciples?"

"Well, she definitely deserves it!"

"If her partner doesn't drag her down, there's a good chance that her team will become top 10— even top 3!"

Meanwhile, Ai Wan and Wei Kang turned to look at Fei Yuyan with narrowed eyes, wondering if she was the person Song Ling'er was talking

about when she warned them of an 'exceptional' genius that will be in the competition.

A few moments later, everybody in the audience turned to look at the next participant— a somewhat slender figure wearing a black jade mask on his face.

"What the heck? Why's he wearing a mask?"

"What an oddball. He's even the only person wearing a mask there."

"This is Fairy Fei's partner? I hope his zither arts won't become a burden."

The people there already began looking down on Yuan before his performance even began.

'Oh boy...' Senior Zou sighed inwardly, wondering what's going to happen now that they've finally reached this unknown prodigy who could defeat even Song Ling'er in a one-on-one battle.

"W-Wait a second! I recognize him! He was at the park yesterday!"

Someone in the crowd suddenly shouted in a surprised voice, dumbfounding the people around him.

"Park? What park?"

"Oh! I was there too! He was the one who was challenged by Senior Fairy Song to a zither battle, even defeating her one-on-one!"

"What kind of nonsense is that? Senior Fairy Song is the number one zither expert in the Lower Heavens! As if someone in this place could defeat her in a one-on-one zither battle!"

"Trust me, I completely understand why you'd be suspicious because I would be too if I didn't witness it for myself, but once you listen to him play the zither, you'll understand what I said is true! I couldn't sleep last night because his zither music was stuck inside my head!"

"..."

Song Ling'er's eyebrows twitched uncontrollably after hearing the crowd's conversation, yet there was nothing she could say about it.

"Ahem!"

Senior Zou suddenly cleared his throat loudly, causing a small ripple to sweep the place, quickly silencing the noise.

"Go ahead. You may begin." Elder Jing said to Yuan shortly after the place calmed down, completely oblivious of the other two judges that were acting slightly strange.

Yuan nodded his head and proceeded to place his fingers gently on the string without actually touching the strings.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan pulled on the string with his fingers, creating three music notes that actually sounded as though it was only one note, almost like he'd played the three notes simultaneously, and an otherworldly sound echoed in the place.

When the audience heard this music note, their eyes immediately widened with surprise, as they could somehow see the image of an incredibly beautiful flower field in front of them.

"W-What the heck? Am I seeing things? Why do I suddenly see flowers?"

"I am seeing it too! The entire area is filled with beautiful flowers!"

"T-This is..."

The judges' eyes widened with shock when they realized what was happening.

"His music note was so profound that it'd created an illusion for anyone that heard it! This level of zither art is simply legendary! And as far as my knowledge goes, only the Zither Goddess has managed to produce this phenomenon before, and he'd managed to achieve this same phenomenon

using only an ordinary zither!" Senior Zou unconsciously stood up on the platform and stared at Yuan with a gawking look on his face.

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Chapter 207 - Playing Seriously

"Heavens... Who on earth is that participant?" Elder Jing mumbled in a dazed voice as he stared at the figure wearing a black jade mask with wide eyes.

'This Yuan... He wasn't using all of his abilities during our one-on-one? Was he... looking down on me?' Song Ling'er stared at Yuan with clear disbelief in her eyes.

It was simply unthinkable that someone would look down on her—the Sect Master of the Heavenly Melody Academy, feeling an indescribable sensation in her heart after learning this.

Of course, Yuan wasn't purposefully looking down on Song Ling'er during their one-on-one; it was just that he didn't feel being so serious in a friendly competition between two zither players, and he saw it more of a friendly spar.

However, as someone who was conditioned to perform his very best during competitions, now that he was actually participating in one, he'd unconsciously flipped his 'serious' switch on and played the zither with absolute focus and seriousness, especially since this is a music competition.

Meanwhile, the audience and the participants alike stared at Yuan with shock and disbelief written all over their faces. Although most of the spectators didn't comprehend the situation and just how amazing Yuan's performance just now truly was, they knew that it was the best thing they've heard today and most likely their entire lives.

As for the other participants, they were gobsmacked by Yuan's performance, and they could still see the illusion of flowers even though

many moments had passed since they heard the three music notes!

'Yuan... you...'

Even Fei Yuyan was staring at Yuan with a gawking expression on her face, feeling her heart racing at this moment.

After a long moment of silence that lasted for a few minutes, Song Ling'er finally snapped out of her daze, and for the first time in this competition, she gave a verdict first, "Ten points."

However, she didn't say anything else. No praises, no opinions— nothing, almost like she was speechless.

Senior Zou and Elder Jing followed a moment later, and they also only gave their verdict without any other words.

"Ten points..."

"Ten points..."

Despite having the first participant to receive a perfect score in this competition, the audience did not explode with excitement or cheering and remained relatively silent, most likely because they were still trying to grasp the situation.

By the time most of these spectators returned to their senses, the judges had already given their verdict and moved onto the next team.

However, the next team did not seem to be in the right mindset when it was finally their turn, and when they tried to play the zither, it sounded almost as though it was their first time touching the zither, or they'd completely forgotten how to play it.

"Zero points."

"Zero from me as well."

"Zero."

The three judges quickly gave their verdict, and for the first time in this competition, right after the first perfect score, the first lowest possible score was achieved.

And to the audiences' surprise, this continued to happen for the next few teams as well. It was almost like every participant that went after Yuan had suddenly lost their ability to play the zither.

This greatly baffled the audience, making them wonder if Yuan had purposefully screwed with the other participants, which should be considered cheating.

However, the judges didn't say anything about it, so there was nothing the audience could say. Even when someone wanted to raise their voice, they would suddenly recall Yuan's otherworldly performance, which quickly made them change their mind. After all, there was no need for someone with such talents to cheat in a competition.

An hour later, the final team received their verdict for the first part of the competition.

And by the end of the first part of the competition, over half of the participants were disqualified due to their unsatisfactory results with only a few hundred teams left.

"That is the end of the first part," Senior Zou said, and he continued, "For the second part of the competition, we will have the teams play a song together."

"Finally we get to listen to some real music!"

"I have been waiting for this!"

The audience was hyped. Although the first part of the competition was exciting in its own ways, it was too short for the audience to truly immerse themselves in the music, as it would end after three quick notes.

Sometime later, Senior Zou continued, "Since this is a partnered competition, you should've practiced with your partner. Therefore, we'll let you decide on the songs you want to play."

"You have three minutes to perform, but any of us judges can decide to cut it short if they find it displeasing to the ears."

Senior Zou then pointed to the team in the front and said, "We'll start from you. You have one minute to discuss with your partner and prepare for your song. As for the other teams, you are not allowed to talk with each other until it's your turn or you will be automatically disqualified. Begin."

Immediately, the two people in that team began talking with each other, deciding which song they should play.

Thirty seconds later, the participants took a deep breath and began playing the zither simultaneously.

A very pleasant-sounding noise flowed throughout the area and into the audiences' ears.

The majority of the audience was quickly attracted by the music and became immersed in it.

However, thirty seconds into the song, when the team made their first mistake with a single out-of-tune note, Song Ling'er's voice resounded, "That's enough."

The music immediately stopped after her words resounded, and the participants lifted their heads to look at Song Ling'er's face that had a slight frown on her beautiful face, their back and forehead soaked in cold sweats.

"This is a team competition— not a solo. You've clearly not practiced with each other enough to screw up so early into the song. You're disqualified." Song Ling'er said a moment later in a cold voice, crushing that team's hopes into pieces.

Chapter 208 - God Descends From Heaven

After the first team was disqualified, they continued onto the second team, who was shaking a little, obviously quite nervous after seeing what happened.

"Begin." Senior Zou said to them.

Fifty-five seconds later, the team began playing their music.

Luckily for this team, they'd managed to calm down enough within those fifty-five seconds to play more than half of the song without making any mistakes.

However, in the end, they made a couple of mistakes towards the end, which resulted in even more mistakes because they thought Song Ling'er was going to immediately disqualify them for a single mistake.

But to their surprise, Song Ling'er did not disqualify them right away.

Once the judgment began, Senior Zou said, "It was pretty decent at the beginning, but after your first mistake, like a ripple effect, the rest of your song became riddled with mistakes. Two points."

"I enjoyed the first half, so I'll give you three points at the very least," said Elder Jing.

Song Ling'er then said, "Zero points. You're disqualified."

The third team began playing their song a couple of moments later.

But alas, just like the first team, they were immediately disqualified by Song Ling'er after their first mistake before the thirty-second mark.

"It looks like Senior Fairy Song intends on disqualifying those who make mistakes early."

"Man, I cannot imagine what it would be like to be one of her disciples. They must be under a lot of stress with her straight and unforgiving character."

"If you want to be the very best, you have to sacrifice some things in your life..."

Half an hour and a dozen disqualified teams later, the first team to make zero mistakes during their performance finally appeared.

"Finally, someone competent." Senior Zou said, and he continued, "The performance was pretty amazing overall, your music notes were in sync, the pace was neither too fast nor too slow, and your techniques were smooth and precise. Ten points from me."

"I agree with Senior Zou. Ten points from me as well." Elder Jing said.

"Seven points." Song Ling'er said, surprising the audience with her high score.

"Who are those two?! They also received somewhat high scores from Senior Fairy Song in the last part as well!"

Some of the audience that did not recognize the team then asked the others.

"That's Zhao Jieyu and Zhao Chengjiao. They're siblings that placed 2nd and 3rd in the last competition."

"Wow! Second and third place?! Their family must be grinning from ear to ear!"

A couple of hours later, it was finally Ai Wan and Wei Kang's turn to perform once again, and the audience immediately straightened their backs

with some even leaning forward from anticipation.

"What song should we play?" Ai Wan asked Wei Kang.

"God Descends from Heaven!" Wei Kang quickly responded without hesitation.

"What?! You want to play God Descends from Heaven? That's one of the most difficult songs in existence! There's no way we can play this song without making any mistakes!" Ai Wan said to him with a look of surprise on her face.

And she continued, "We're already behind that team with Fei Yuyan and that mysterious masked person! We cannot risk losing any more points!"

"They are exactly the reason why we must take this risk! Do you think we'll defeat them without going all out? Did you not hear that masked person's three music notes? There's no way we can defeat someone like that if we don't go all out!"

Ai Wan turned silent for a moment after hearing Wei Kang's words, and then she nodded a moment later with a serious expression on her face, "You're right, Wei Kang. Our Master told us to not be complacent. If we don't take this seriously and lose first place, we'll be a laughing stock!"

"Are you ready?" Senior Zou asked them since they took a little over a minute to discuss.

"Yes, we are." Wei Kang said to him.

A few seconds later, the two of them began playing the zither, and a dozen unique music notes appeared in quick succession, dumbfounding the audience with their face-paced music.

"T-This song is God Descends from Heaven! One of the most difficult songs in this world with over ten thousand music notes, and they're going to play this in a competition?! As expected of Senior Fairy Song's disciples — they're very bold!"

"Heavens! Look at how fast they're playing the zither!"

"Legends has it that a god had descended to the Lower Heavens from the upper realms when this song was first created, hence its name!"

Meanwhile, Senior Zou and Elder Jing looked at Ai Wan and Wei Kang with surprised looks on their faces. Even they can't play the God Descends from Heaven song perfectly, yet these two are going to play it in a duet during a competition?

And as one would've expected, Ai Wan and Wei Kang made plenty of mistakes during their performance— over a hundred mistakes before the thirty-second mark, yet Song Ling'er did not disqualify them and allowed them to continue to play this seemingly impossible song.

However, they were also playing the music too quickly for most people to notice these mistakes, so only the top experts like the judges were able to discern these mistakes.

'What fast-paced, chaotic music... This is my first time hearing such a song...' Yuan glared at these two people with narrowed eyes, clearly piqued by their music.

Exactly three minutes later, Ai Wan and Wei Kang stopped playing at the exact same time with their last music note rippling throughout the place, their faces and body soaked in sweat.

Three seconds later, once the audience realized that the music had stopped, the entire place exploded with cheering that shook the atmosphere there.

Sometime later, Senior Zou said while clapping, "Even though there were many mistakes in your performance, I cannot help but still admire your courage for playing this song during a competition, even playing it to the end without any major mistakes or obvious off syncs. And this is my first time hearing the God Descends from Heaven song during a competition despite my experience. Therefore, I am going to give you ten points."

Chapter 209 - Perfectly In Sync

After Senior Zou's verdict, Elder Jing spoke, "Above and beyond— that's all I can say. Ten points from me as well."

Everybody then turned to look at Song Ling'er, who nodded her head and said, "I see that you've finally understood the situation you're in, Wei Kang."

"Yes, Master!" Wei Kang said with a serious look on his face.

"Although there were many mistakes in your performance, I do not expect anyone to play the God Descends from Heaven song perfectly, especially not in a duet. You get nine points from me."

The crowd cheered after hearing Song Ling'er's verdict. Although it was not a perfect score, neither was their performance, so it was fully justified for once.

"Thank you, Master!"

Ai Wan and Wei Kang bowed to her before sitting back down and exchanging satisfied looks with each other. Then they turned to look at Yuan, who was calmly sitting there and staring at his zither with a pondering gaze.

'What's he thinking about?' They couldn't help but wonder to themselves after seeing Yuan's bright eyes that gave them an ominous feeling for some reason.

The competition continued, and just like previously, after Ai Wan and Wei Kang's performance, the rest of the participants appeared to be lacking in their performance, causing the audience to grow bored.

Sometime later, when they finally reached Yuan's team, the audience immediately straightened their backs and widened their eyes with anticipation flickering within.

"It's them! Fairy Fei and her mysterious partner!"

"I wonder what kind of surprise they'll bring this time and how their performance will compare to Ai Wan and Wei Kang's performance!"

Meanwhile, Fei Yuyan asked Yuan, "What song should we play?"

However, almost as though he couldn't hear her, Yuan remained silent and continued staring at his zither with a dazed look on his face.

"Disciple Yuan?" Fei Yuyan called out to him again.

"Eh? I'm sorry, I was thinking about something. What did you just say?" Yuan snapped out of his daze and turned to look at her with a puzzled look on his face.

"It's our turn to perform," Fei Yuyan said with her eyebrows raised, and she continued, "What song should we play? After Senior Song's disciples' performance, it'll be hard for us to compete since we don't know any difficult songs like Gods Descending from Heaven."

Yuan then said, "Do you remember that one song we played during our practice when we stayed up all night? Let's play that song."

Fei Yuyan's eyes widened, and then she said, "A-Are you sure about that? That song... It's too unique. What if the judges don't like it? I think it'd be safer if we played one of my songs."

"It'll be fine. It may be a bit unique compared to the music you're used to, but this is a competition to see how well we can play the song as partners. Anyway, just play as we did during practice—I'll follow your pace." Yuan said to her with a smile behind his mask.

Fei Yuyan nodded with a serious look on her face, and then she turned to look at her zither.

'I cannot be a burden to Yuan...'

After taking a deep breath, Fei Yuyan moved her slender arms and began playing the zither with her fair hands.

Yuan followed Fei Yuyan's movements and played the zither at the exact time she did.

"W-What the? What kind of music is this?"

The audience was immediately taken aback by the unique-sounding music that had a theme they've never heard before.

However, not every single spectator in the audience was unfamiliar with this type of music.

"Wait a second... Why does this music sound so familiar?"

"H-Hey! That's a famous song from our world! Why do they know such a song?!"

The players in the audience were baffled once they realized that this song being played was a song from their modern world, especially the players that were among the participants there!

Unless a fellow player taught them this song, there was only one other reason why they would know this song! One of them was a player! And since most of the NPCs there knew Fei Yuyan, it could only mean that the figure wearing the black jade mask was a player!

'That person was a fellow player this entire time? My god! Why is he so good at the zither already?! Did he pick up the zither the moment he started playing this game?!'

"Just who is behind that black mask?!" The participants that were players wondered.

Meanwhile, the judges were baffled by not only the unique song but also their perfect performance that flowed smoothly and was also flawlessly in

sync.

In their eyes, it was almost as though Yuan and Fei Yuyan had become a single entity playing one song.

"T-This is..." Song Ling'er almost couldn't believe her eyes.

'Impossible! The reason they sound so perfectly in sync is not because they are used to playing together—it's because Yuan is following Fei Yuyan's rhythm flawlessly!'

Although most of the people there may not be aware of the situation, Song Ling'er knew exactly how shocking Yuan's performance was.

While Fei Yuyan only needed to play the song at her own pace, Yuan had to imitate Fei Yuyan's movements and follow her pace without making any mistakes; it was an incredibly difficult thing to do even for top experts, and only those who fully grasp their partners' skills would be able to achieve such a thing.

Of course, even Fei Yuyan herself was not aware of this, and she continued to play the zither innocently.

A few minutes later, Fei Yuyan stopped playing the zither, and the music immediately halted without any delays, almost like she was the only one who was playing the zither this entire time.

However, the audience appeared to be a little puzzled afterward.

"Is it just me or was their performance a little bit disappointing? It didn't have the same impact as their previous performance..."

"Right? Although the song was unique and very pleasant-sounding, it wasn't as exciting as I thought it'd be..."

"Compared to Ai Wan and Wei Kang, their performance is definitely lacking."

Completely oblivious to the 'real' performance behind Yuan and Fei Yuyan's show just now, the audience expressed their disappointment.

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Chapter 210 - Thirteen Points

After Yuan and Fei Yuyan's performance, the judges pondered before giving their verdict.

Elder Jing turned to look at Senior Zou and Song Ling'er. Since he was the least experienced out of the three, he wanted to let the experts go first so that his judgment isn't too far off, causing him to lose face.

However, neither Senior Zou nor Song Ling'er spoke even many moments later, causing Elder Jing to raise his eyebrows.

Then he turned to look at Yuan and Fei Yuyan. After clearing his throat, Elder Jing gave his verdict first for the first time.

"This is my first time hearing such unique music, and I must say, it was definitely a positive new experience overall. The synchronization between the two of you was also fantastic. However, compared to your previous performance, especially you, young man in the black mask, it was quite lacking and a disappointment if I am being honest. I had expected much more, but alas... Seven points from me."

"..."

The audience was silent throughout Elder Jing's verdict, and nobody made any noises afterward, as they also felt that it was quite a fair assessment.

However, Senior Zou and Song Ling'er turned to look at Elder Jing with frowns on their faces.

'This guy... He also couldn't fathom their performance?' Senior Zou was speechless, but he wasn't too shocked, since he also almost missed it.

Senior Zou then turned to look at Song Ling'er, who held a frown even deeper than his own on her beautiful face, causing him to swallow nervously.

"I... I will give you ten points." Senior Zou suddenly said, dumbfounding Elder Jing and the audience.

"What? Ten points? Are you sure about your verdict, Daoist Zou? I don't mean to doubt your judgment, but how could you give them a similar score to what you gave Ai Wan and Wei Kang who was clearly superior? I hope you aren't still affected by their previous performance..." Elder Jing couldn't help but question Senior Zou's decision.

Senior Zou shook his head and said, "I'll let Senior Song explain..."

They turned to look at Song Ling'er, who spoke in a calm yet cold voice a moment later, "If you cannot fathom why Daoist Zou gave them ten points instead of a disgraceful seven points, you do not qualify to be a judge in this competition. If not for my respect for the Heaven and Earth Palace, I would have you removed from your position as judge already."

After her cold remarks, shocking Elder Jing, Song Ling'er turned to look at Fei Yuyan and Yuan.

"Once again, you have exceeded my expectations. Ten... No, thirteen points from me." Song Ling'er said, her gaze directly on Yuan's figure.

"W-What? Did Senior Fairy Song just say 'thirteen points'?"

"Unless we are all hearing things— I think she did..."

"Is it even possible to give more than ten points? And why thirteen points?"

"Maybe it's to make up for Elder Jing's seven points, making it a total of 30 points..."

"Why would she do that, though? Even Senior Zou gave them ten points. I cannot fathom their reasons for doing so."

"Perhaps there was something about their performance that only those two noticed? After all, they're the judges."

The audience went into an uproar after hearing Senior Zou and Song Ling'er's puzzling verdict.

After all, how could they give Yuan's team a perfect score when Ai Wan and Wei Kang couldn't achieve that kind of score after playing God Descends from Heaven, a song that's objectively harder to play?

"You must be wondering why I gave you such a score." Song Ling'er suddenly said as she looked at Fei Yuyan's direction who held a confused look on her face.

Upon hearing Song Ling'er's words, Fei Yuyan nodded with a dazed look on her face. While she was pretty satisfied with their performance, she didn't think it was worthy of such a high score.

Song Ling'er then said, "Your performance overall was great, but it wasn't anything too amazing, and it would be worth at most 7 points if not for the other factors."

"The other factors...?" Fei Yuyan raised her eyebrows.

Song Ling'er nodded and said, "Your partner's performance."

'Yuan's performance?'

Song Ling'er continued, "Your partner displayed a shocking level of talent and skills by following your pace flawlessly, which earned the extra points. I normally wouldn't do something like this, but I know very well that he could've performed much better if he wasn't limited by you."

"If he'd played the zither at his own level without any restrictions, the performance would've definitely turned out better. However, if he'd done that, you would not have been able to play together, simply because of the fact that the disparity between your abilities is just that vast, and this is not

a solo competition, so he sacrificed his own performance in order to match yours."

"..."

Fei Yuyan was shocked speechless after learning the real reason behind their verdict, and she turned to look at Yuan with a pained expression on her face.

"I'm sorry, Disciple Yuan... It seems like I will be a burden to you no matter what I do..." Fei Yuyan said to him a moment later with teary eyes.

"I..." Yuan didn't know what he should say in this situation since this is the first time he's been put into such an awkward situation.

"You don't have to say anything to me. I know that I cannot compare to you, nor can I catch up to you, and that's not your fault. Although I may continue to be a burden until the end of this competition, let's play to the best of our abilities, okay?" Fei Yuyan said to him after wiping her eyes and showing him a smile.

"..."

After a moment of silence, Yuan suddenly turned to look at Song Ling'er and said, "I have a suggestion, Senior Song."

"What is it?" Song Ling'er raised her eyebrows in a curious manner.

"As you'd said, I didn't perform at my best, and our performance was only above average, so we don't deserve such a high score no matter how you spin it. Therefore, allow me—by myself—to play another song to make up for the points, or at least justify it somewhat." Yuan said, surprising her and everyone there.

Chapter 211 - Temporary Buff

"You... want to play a song by yourself?" Song Ling'er raised her eyebrows.

Under normal circumstances, that would not be allowed, as this is a competition— a partnered competition. However, she really wanted to listen to Yuan play the zither seriously by himself even if it would invalidate the integrity of the competition. After all, in her eyes, he was going to win this competition regardless.

"Okay, go ahead." Song Ling'er nodded her head a moment later, surprising the audience.

"Senior Song, are you sure? This isn't part of the competition..." Elder Jing said in a nervous voice.

"Who cares? If he wants to play, let him play," Senior Zou said with a smile on his face.

"You too, Daoist Zou...?" Elder Jing was dumbfounded. Why did they want to listen to this participant play so much? It was almost as though they were subtly favoring him!

"Thank you, Seniors..." Yuan said to them before focusing on the zither.

He then closed his eyes to recall a certain face-paced song that was played only recently.

A few moments later, after taking a deep breath, Yuan began playing the zither, and his hands moved with extreme speed.

Ting~!

A very familiar-sounding song began playing, dumbfounding the audience and the judges alike.

"T-This song is—?!"

"God Descends from Heaven! He's actually playing God Descends from Heaven!"

"So he actually knows this song as well!"

Song Ling'er and the other judges watched with bulging eyes as Yuan played God Descends from Heaven flawlessly and at a pace that sounded even faster than Ai Wan and Wei Kang when they performed.

Meanwhile, Fei Yuyan stared at Yuan with a gawking expression on her face. Although nobody else there was aware, she knew that not only did Yuan start playing the zither only a week ago but he has also never heard or played the song God Descends from Heaven until today!

'He can play God Descends from Heaven after listening to it a single time...? Just how heaven-defying are his musical talents? How does his mind operate?' Fei Yuyan couldn't help but cry inwardly, feeling like this is Yuan's most shocking moment to date.

'This guy is a fucking monster! How can he play one of the most difficult songs with seemingly no effort at all?!' Wei Kang cursed inwardly as he watched Yuan's finger movements flow as smoothly as water and with precision, almost like he was a music machine or something similar.

"L-Look behind him! Am I seeing things or is there someone floating behind him?!" One of the spectators suddenly pointed at Yuan and shouted in a shocked voice.

"No, you're right! I also see it! What a beauty!"

"This must be another illusion!"

"It's almost like a goddess has descended from the heavens because of his music!"

The audience was shocked when a beautiful young lady with peerless features suddenly appeared behind Yuan halfway through the song like a spirit guardian watching over him.

"T-That's—!" Senior Zou shook uncontrollably and stood up after seeing the beautiful figure floating behind Yuan.

Although it took a moment for him to recognize her face, it was, without doubt, the Zither Goddess behind Yuan!

'W-Why am I seeing the illusion of the Zither Goddess behind him? What's the meaning of this?'

Meanwhile, Song Ling'er subconsciously placed her hands onto her chest, and she could feel her heart beating almost as fast as Yuan was playing the zither.

Exactly three minutes later, Yuan stopped playing the zither with the last music note creating a ripple that spread throughout the area and snapping everyone out of their daze.

As for the players there, a notification popped up for them.

[Your stats has been increased by 10% for 30 minutes from the effects of 'God Descending from Heaven']

To their surprise, they'd received a temporary buff after listening to Yuan's zither arts!

"Phew... What an amazing song..." Yuan took a deep breath after the song ended, feeling extremely satisfied despite making a couple of mistakes.

In fact, one of the major reasons why he suggested playing a song by himself was simply so that he could play God Descends from Heaven while it was still fresh inside his mind, even using the score as an excuse to play the song.

Yuan then turned to look at the judges and said, "I have finished. Thank you for listening to my selfish request."

The place turned dead silent, to the point where even a pin drop could be heard miles away.

Sometime later, Song Ling'er said in a somewhat shaky voice, "I... I think I have seen enough today."

"Eh? What do you mean by that, Senior Song?" Elder Jing couldn't help but ask her.

Song Ling'er then stood up and said in a loud and clear voice, "There's no need for us to continue this when the results are clear. Therefore, I am ending this competition here."

"WHAT?!"

The audience, participants, and judges alike stared at Song Ling'er with disbelief in their eyes, as they couldn't believe that she'd cut the competition short just like that!

However, if they thought about it, after witnessing Yuan's performance, it was clear who would receive first place so Song Ling'er's decision made some sense!

"S-Senior Song... T-This is a partnered competition... I don't think it'll be fair for the other participants if we end the competition because of a single outstanding participant." Elder Jing said in a nervous tone.

Song Ling'er glared at Elder Jing, but she didn't say anything. She then pointed at the participants and said, "Look at their faces. Do they look like people with the will to continue? And I don't need to sit through the entire competition to know who'll obtain what place."

Elder Jing turned to look at the participants, and sure enough, the majority of them held bitter expressions on their faces and their aura without any motivation or confidence. Even if they continued with the competition, their performances would be lackluster at best.

"W-What about the second and third place? There has to be more than one winner..." Elder Jing then said.

Song Ling'er glanced at the participants before speaking in an indifferent voice, "The rewards are too good for them! The second and third place will remain empty! If you have a problem with that, go ahead and challenge me!"

Author's Note: Since we've managed to take first place for win-win, I will be giving a five-chapter mass release later, probably sometime during the middle of the month since I am very busy now.

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Chapter 212 - Player Yuans First Public Appearance

Chapter 212 - Player Yuan's First Public Appearance

The place fell into silence once again after Song Ling'er's domineering words, and the participants trembled at the thought of challenging Song Ling'er.

The participants then turned to look at Yuan who suddenly looked much bigger than previously, almost like he'd grown a few sizes. However, that was just their admiration for Yuan making it seem like he was bigger than normal.

After witnessing his god-like performance that'd seemingly summoned a goddess instead of a god, they did not feel like competing against such a monster.

Suddenly, someone within the participants stood up and approached Yuan.

The others there turned to look at this individual, who was Wei Kang.

Once he was standing before Yuan, to everybody's surprise, Wei Kang lowered his head and bowed to Yuan before speaking in a respectful voice, "Congratulations on winning the competition, Senior. You definitely deserve it even though the whole thing was somewhat abnormal and unprecedented."

"L-Look! That arrogant Wei Kang is lowering his head to someone else that isn't Senior Fairy Song!"

"I can see that for myself!"

A few moments later, Ai Wan followed Wei Kang's footsteps and also bowed to Yuan in a respectful manner.

"Hello, Senior. I am Ai Wan, and I would like to thank you for opening my eyes today. This may sound a little disrespectful to my master, but you have broadened my views with your zither arts. Hopefully, we can play the zither together in the future."

Yuan nodded at them and said, "Thank you. If there's ever a chance, let's play the zither together."

Sometime later, Song Ling'er asked the other two judges, "Do you have anything else to say? If you are not satisfied with the results, we can talk about it."

Senior Zou quickly shook his head and said, "No, there's no need. I already knew the results of this competition the moment he played the Soul Ensnaring Zither before my very eyes, and if I was as daring as you, Senior Song, I would've also ended the competition early."

"What about you, Elder Jing? Do you have something else to add?" Senior Zou then asked Elder Jing, who quickly shook his head.

"Do whatever you want. I am only here because my sect is sponsoring the competition. Otherwise, I wouldn't even be here." Elder Jing shrugged.

"Then it's decided."

They turned to look at Song Ling'er, who nodded.

A few moments later, Song Ling'er turned to look at Yuan and Fei Yuyan and spoke in a loud voice that resounded clearly, "This concludes the zither competition! Congratulations to the winners, Fei Yuyan and 'Yuan' from the Dragon Essence Temple, for achieving first place in this competition!"

"W-What did she just say?"

"Huh? Did I just hear 'Yuan'?"

The players there stared at the figure wearing the black jade mask with shocked looks on their faces.

Literally, three seconds later, a large notification appears directly above the competition, confirming the players' doubt.

[Congratulations to the participants that have attained the top three for this event!]

[First Place: Player Yuan]

[Second Place: N/A]

[Third Place: N/A]

[Player Yuan's brilliant performance that mesmerized millions of spectators as well as the judges with his zither arts has achieved first place and will be given a special reward for his achievements!]

In front of Yuan, a couple of notifications appeared.

[Due to your performance in the zither competition, you have gained a massive amount of fame!]

[Fame +1,000]

[You have gained the title 'Zither Prodigy' for obtaining first place in the zither competition]

[Because of your title 'Zither Prodigy', spiritual music played from a zither will have an enhanced effect, increasing its buff strength by 50%!]

"What?! He's really Player Yuan! The currently leading player who's rumored to be a cheater!"

"Impossible! I thought he was a little girl! I knew I couldn't have trusted those bullshit rumors!"

"So that's Player Yuan! He's somehow exactly as I imagined! Mysterious and all!"

The Players were excited to see this infamous Player Yuan for the first time with their very eyes, as there have been only speculations about his existence this entire time. In fact, some of them even believed that Yuan was created by the creators of this game to fool the players!

"Does this mean he's really a Player and not some NPC created by the creators? Heavens! I can see the forums exploding once they find out about this!"

"They said he's from the Dragon Essence Temple, right? This is huge news! Maybe we'll even get to speak with him soon!"

Meanwhile, the players within the participants felt an urge to approach Yuan and speak with him, perhaps even shake his hands, but alas, Song Ling'er had just left the judges' platform and stood before Yuan, preventing anybody from approaching them with her immense aura.

"Follow me so I can distribute your rewards for your achievements," Song Ling'er said to them.

Fei Yuyan and Yuan nodded, and they followed Song Ling'er into the building, leaving everyone else behind.

Once Yuan left the area, the players there immediately began logging out of the game and jumping straight into the forums for Cultivation Online, spamming the place with new threads.

[Breaking News! Player Yuan has appeared in the zither competition!]

[Shocking new information about Player Yuan has surfaced!]

[Player Yuan is currently a disciple at the Dragon Essence Temple!]

The online forums were bombarded with new threads regarding Yuan, and the forums quickly flared with excitement from this new information.

The news traveled so fast that Yu Rou, who was still at school, was already hearing about it.

"Did you hear?! They say Player Yuan has appeared in the zither competition that a couple of our students had participated in! This is his first public appearance ever!"

"What! Really?! What did he look like?!"

"He was wearing a mask so they couldn't see his face properly, but he was a tall and slender man!"

"So he wasn't a little girl? I was right to not listen to the previous rumors regarding his gender!"

"Anyway, this is huge news! I'm sure there will be a lot of people visiting the Dragon Essence Temple now that they know his whereabouts!"

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Chapter 213 - Zither Competition Rewards

'They're talking about Brother Tian?' Yu Rou listened to the conversation between her classmates without turning to look at them, as she didn't want to make it seem like she was interested.

However, Meixiu was a different case, and she listened to the conversation while looking at them with a pondering look on her face.

'Player Yuan... first place? If I remember correctly, the Young Master is also participating in a music competition inside the game...' Meixiu thought to herself.

As someone who has been with the sibling for her entire life, she knew very well the extent of Yu Tian's talents, and she found it hard to believe that someone other than Yu Tian would achieve first place in a music competition. In fact, Yu Tian has never received anything lower than first place, so it was always expected that he would achieve first place no matter what kind of competition he participated in.

'Perhaps the Young Master is participating in a different competition? After all, I heard the world in Cultivation Online is countless times larger than our own world.'

"Sister Rou!"

Someone suddenly approached Yu Rou from behind and called out to her.

Yu Rou turned around to see an innocent-looking young lady with long wavy brown hair, a slim figure, and two large meat buns on her chest

standing behind her.

"Xia Jingyi," Yu Rou smiled at her.

"It's time for lunch, Sister Rou. Let's go eat."

"Okay." Yu Rou nodded and stood up from her seat before following this pretty young lady outside.

On her way outside, the other classmates in the room watched her leave without turning their heads, their gazes filled with admiration and respect.

Once they were outside the classroom, Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi went to sit at a clean table somewhere in the large courtyard in the middle of the school.

"Here's your lunch, Young Lady." Meixiu placed a large and luxurious-looking lunchbox on the table.

"Thank you, Meixiu. You can also take a seat and eat with us," Yu Rou said to her.

However, Meixiu shook her head and said, "I'm afraid I cannot act so familiar with the Young Lady at school..."

Yu Rou sighed, "Do whatever you want..."

After eating their lunch quickly but elegantly, Xia Jingyi said, "Sister Rou, I'm sure you've heard by now— about Player Yuan! He's made another appearance! A public one this time!"

A smile appeared on Yu Rou's face, and she said, "Of course. After all, everyone else in my class was talking about it. I would hear about it even if I didn't want to."

"I almost couldn't believe it when I heard it! To think Player Yuan is also a musical genius! It's almost like there's nothing in this world that he cannot do!" Xia Jingyi said in an excited voice, her admiration for Player Yuan as clear as day.

"You really admire this Player Yuan, huh?" Yu Rou said with a somewhat mysterious smile on her face.

Even though Xia Jingyi is her best friend for many years and someone she trusts fully, she never thought about revealing Yuan's real identity to her.

"Of course! Everything about his existence intrigues me! Aren't you also curious about his background? His real identity!" Xia Jingyi said to her.

"Well... I was..." Yu Rou said in a somewhat awkward voice.

"Past tense? What's that supposed to mean? Did you lose interest?" Xia Jingyi looked at her with raised eyebrows.

"Something like that." Yu Rou nodded.

And she continued, "What are you going to do if you learn his identity, anyway?"

"I don't know, but I'll probably ask him to be my friend or something."

"Your friend...?" Yu Rou couldn't help but chuckle at her words.

"Anyway, are you ready to play Cultivation Online with me this weekend? I will be playing the game for the first time tonight." Xia Jingyi asked her.

Yu Rou nodded and said, "Just let me know where you start and I'll see if we can play together."

"Okay! I'll let you know tomorrow!" Xia Jingyi said.

Sometime later, they returned to their classrooms to continue with their school day.

Meanwhile, inside the game, Yuan followed Song Ling'er to this small room somewhere inside the building.

"Since you've achieved first place and there is no second or third place, I'll give you the rewards for first place as well as second place," said Song

Ling'er as she retrieved the treasures and placed them onto the table.

Fei Yuyan stared at the Divine-grade Zither and Divine-rank Zither Arts with a dazed look on her face, as this is her first time being so close to something so precious.

'Wow... So this is what a Divine-grade treasure looks like...'

However, Fei Yuyan quickly shook her head, and then she turned to look at Yuan and said, "Go ahead, Disciple Yuan. You can take the rewards for the first place and I'll settle with the second place rewards. After all, you are the only reason we've made it this far, and I am not shameless enough to ask for something so precious when I know that I don't deserve it."

"Are you sure? We entered this competition as a team, so regardless of our contribution, we should share the rewards." Yuan said to her.

"Disciple Yuan..." A sweet smile appeared on Fei Yuyan's face, but she insisted that he accept the treasure.

"I know that you're trying to make me feel better but don't— you'll actually make me feel worse and filled with guilt if I accepted the first place rewards."

"Hmmm..."

Yuan remained silent for a moment to ponder.

A few moments later, he said, "How about this? I'll take the Divine-grade Zither, and I'll also take the Divine-rank Zither Arts. However, I'll only keep the Divine-rank Zither Arts until I learn the technique, and I'll give it to you right after I am done with it so that you can use it as well. It'll only be a few days at most."

"A few days at most... But this is a Divine-rank technique we're talking about..." Fei Yuyan and Song Ling'er stared at Yuan with wide eyes filled with disbelief.

Chapter 214 - End Of The Zither Competition

"Y-You don't have to give yourself a deadline, Disciple Yuan. You can give it to me whenever you are finished with it. There's no need to rush it. I highly doubt anybody can learn a Divine-rank technique in just a few days. Zither Arts may not be as complicated as some cultivation techniques, but it's still a Divine-rank technique nevertheless." Fei Yuyan said to Yuan after hearing his words that sounded like bragging.

"Okay." Yuan didn't argue with Fei Yuyan and nodded his head before tossing the Divine-grade Zither and the Divine-rank Zither Arts into his spatial ring.

[Congratulations! You have obtained a Divine-grade treasure!]

[Congratulations! You have obtained a Divine-rank technique!]

After accepting the rewards, a notification appeared in the sky for all of the players to see.

[Player Yuan has obtained a Divine-grade treasure!]

[Player Yuan has become the first Player to have obtained a Divine-grade treasure!]

Once both Yuan and Fei Yuyan stored away their treasures, Song Ling'er said to them, "Now that I've given you one of the rewards, let's continue onto the second reward."

"Eh? There are more rewards?" Fei Yuyan looked at Song Ling'er with wide eyes.

Song Ling'er nodded her head and said, "Did you already forget what I said at the beginning of the competition? That I would accept the first place as my disciples?"

"Y-You mean... You want to accept us as your own disciples? You weren't joking about that?" Fei Yuyan's jaw dropped to the ground. After all, she could've never imagined that she would one day have the opportunity to become the famous Song Ling'er's disciple!

"Why would I joke about something like that before so many people?" Song Ling'er responded with a serious look on her face.

"Though to tell you the truth, I originally only wanted to accept Yuan as my disciple, but after seeing your talents that could compete even with my current disciples, I have decided to also make you my disciple." Song Ling'er said to Fei Yuyan, not hiding her true intentions.

"But we're still disciples of the Dragon Essence Temple... We cannot just accept someone from another sect as our Master, especially me, since I am already a Core Disciple." Fei Yuyan said to her, mostly as an excuse.

"It'll be fine. What I will be teaching you will not interfere with the Dragon Essence Temple's teachings, and I will even speak to your Sect Master about this. Furthermore, it's not impossible to accept a master from another sect since that has happened many times in the past."

Song Ling'er then turned to Yuan and continued, "I know you don't want to leave the Dragon Essence Temple so I'll allow you to stay at the Dragon Essence Temple while being my disciple at the same time. This way, you won't have to leave your sect while being able to study under me at the same time."

However, Yuan said, "I appreciate your considerations, Senior Song, but I really don't intend on focusing on the zither too much. After all, I am already studying the sword and the dagger."

"You're what?"

Both Fei Yuyan and Song Ling'er stared at him with wide eyes again.

Seeing their expressions that were filled with disbelief, Yuan decided to retrieve the Empyrean Overlord and the Starry Abyss to prove to them that he indeed practiced with swords and daggers.

"See? I am playing the zither mostly as a hobby, and I do not intend on focusing too much on it."

"T-That's ridiculous! How can you toss away such a heaven-sent talent like this! I won't allow it!" Song Ling'er said with a frown on her face, clearly unwilling to see someone as talented as Yuan letting his talent go to waste.

And before Yuan could even respond, Fei Yuyan spoke, "I have to agree with Senior Song here, Disciple Yuan. You have the capabilities to become one of the greatest zither experts in the world. Why would you not focus on this path instead? Can you at least give us your reason?"

A bitter smile appeared on Yuan's face, and he proceeded to tell them a little about his past when he was still active as a musician and how his parents would force him to play, working him like a machine.

"Although I like music— even love— I simply cannot find myself focusing on music like it's the only thing in my life, as I have already found other things in life that I am interested in. The sword and the dagger are only some of many examples."

"Perhaps I might return to that path in the future, but for now, while I still can, I want to enjoy everything else this world has to offer."

"..."

Song Ling'er and Fei Yuyan remained speechless for a few moments after hearing Yuan's background.

"Fine... If you don't want to focus on this path then I won't force you, since that'll only do more negative than positive. However, that doesn't mean I have given up on you because I haven't, and I will never abandon someone

as talented as you, Yuan. Mark my words— I'll make you serious about music again even if it's the last thing I do!"

After saying that, Song Ling'er turned around and walked out of the room.

And just as Yuan and Fei Yuyan prepared to leave the room as well, Elder Shan and Elder Xuan appeared before them with Min Li and Xuan Wuhan behind them.

"Congratulations on achieving first place, Disciple Yuan, Disciple Fei! The Dragon Essence Temple will definitely reward you for your contribution!" Elder Xuan said to them with a wide smile on his face.

"Did Senior Song do anything weird to you, Disciple Yuan?" Elder Shan began patting Yuan all over his body like she was looking for injuries.

"I-I am fine..." Yuan said in a slightly dazed voice.

"Congratulations, Yuan! We'll have to celebrate this occasion when we return to the sect!" Xuan Wuhan said to him.

"Congratulations, Disciple Yuan." Min Li said afterward.

"Thank you all." Yuan nodded with a bright smile on his face, feeling relieved that he did not disappoint anyone.

Chapter 215 - Group Call

After the zither competition ended, Yuan and the others returned to the Royal Blossom Hotel for a moment before checking out of the hotel and making their way back to the Dragon Essence Temple on the sect elders' flying treasures.

Meanwhile, in the real world, many powerful and influential individuals from over a dozen different families from across the world gathered online in a group call.

"We have to do something about this Player Yuan! He's tearing the Legacy Families' reputation to shreds! Every single time his name appears on the announcement, it's a slap to our faces! Even worse, we still don't know his identity!" One of the voices said in a serious voice.

"What do you suggest we do then? We don't know this player's identity, nor does it seem like he wants our money," said another voice.

"No logical being would refuse status and money unless they already have these..." Another person in the group call voiced his opinions.

"Then what can we do? We cannot allow this Player Yuan to continue dominating the game! Cultivation Online has become the most successful and fastest-growing game the world's ever seen before, and it will only continue to grow as more people realize its potential! We cannot allow a single person to monopolize it!"

"Since we cannot contact him from the outside, we can only try to contact him from the inside, right? I heard Player Yuan had appeared in public for the first time day in a music competition, even obtaining a Divine-grade treasure and a Divine-rank technique from it."

"What! Is that true?!"

"Yes, and according to the people that were at this competition, Player Yuan is a disciple at the Dragon Essence Temple in the Eastern Continent."

"Eastern Continent, huh? I have some people from my family in the Eastern Continent who can approach him, but my top player is currently in the Southern Continent so he won't make it," said a new voice that belonged to a female.

"I also have a couple of players in the Eastern Continent that can try to contact Player Yuan," said another voice.

"No disrespect to your families or players, but I wouldn't suggest sending just any players to approach Player Yuan. After all, what if he sees it as a sign of disrespect— that we're underestimating or undervaluing him."

"I agree with Mister Jason. If possible, we should have our top players approach him so that he can feel more comfortable and valued."

"Who here have their top players in the Eastern Continent?"

"What about White Lotus? She's a top player and currently at the Eastern Continent, right?"

"Yes, but she's currently busy in her own sect. I don't think she'll have the time to travel all the way to the Dragon Essence Temple to find him, especially when there's a really important event coming up in the upcoming weeks."

"The Lightning Emperor is also busy with his own sect, so we cannot ask him to meet Player Yuan."

"Most of the top players are all too busy grinding their own strength so they don't fall behind Player Yuan too much. There's nothing we can do."

"Speaking of this upcoming event, what was it called again? Mystic Realm?"

"Yeah, I heard it's one of the biggest events in the Lower Heavens and every top player is aiming for it."

"Does this mean Player Yuan will also be participating in this event? If that's the case, we can simply wait until the top players meet him during this event. It's less than a month away, anyway."

"While I prefer that we contact him sooner than later, if there are no top players that can meet him now, we can only wait until the Mystic Realm. I don't want to risk offending this Player Yuan."

"Furthermore, he must know some secrets about the game that's allowed him to progress so insanely fast. He might even have relationships with the creators of this game that nobody knows about. If we can learn some of these secrets, our own players will also be able to progress as fast if not even faster than him!"

"What about the other families? They will surely do everything in their power to contact him."

"So what? Even if they go to the Dragon Essence Temple, they still need to find Player Yuan amongst the thousands of people there."

"I suggest we send some of our players to the Dragon Essence Temple to investigate. After all, we also don't know his identity. It'll be like finding a needle in a haystack."

"There's no way someone like Player Yuan would be able to hide his identity perfectly. Even if he tries, he's simply too unique."

"Then it's settled. All of us will send some players to the Dragon Essence Temple to investigate. In fact, see if there are any players from our alliance that are already a disciple there. If you receive any new information regarding Player Yuan, notify the rest of us immediately."

The group call ended shortly later, and the people that were in the call began preparing for their investigation in Player Yuan.

In fact, these people were not the only ones in a meeting on this day, as similar conversations between other families had occurred after the zither competition, all planning to approach the Dragon Essence Temple to learn more about this mysterious Player Yuan.

"Welcome back, all of you. I'm relieved to see that all of you have managed to return in one piece." Long Yijun said to Yuan and the others after they returned to the Dragon Essence Temple.

"I have already heard about what happened at the zither competition so you can spare the explanation. Disciple Yuan, Disciple Fei, your achievements have greatly boosted the Dragon Essence Temple's reputation, and for your contribution, the sect will definitely award you appropriately. For now, go home and get some rest. We'll find you once we are prepared to hand the rewards out."

"Thank you, Sect Master!" Fei Yuyan bowed to him, and Yuan followed.

Sometime later, they left the place, leaving Elder Xuan and Elder Shan behind with Long Yijun.

Chapter 216 - Returning To The Dragon Pavilion

Once Yuan and the other disciples left the place, Long Yijun turned to look at Elder Shan and Elder Xuan with a serious expression on his face.

"Tell me everything that has happened," he said to them with a listening look on his face.

Elder Xuan nodded and said, "Allow me to explain first."

He then proceeded to explain everything that had happened during their time outside the sect, leaving almost no detail out, such as Elder Shan's scandalous behavior.

"I see..."

Long Yijun turned to look at Elder Shan and asked, "Do you have anything to add."

"Only one thing," she quickly responded before continuing, "I am certain that there's a Spirit Grandmaster watching over Disciple Yuan in the shadows."

"What!"

Both Long Yijun and Elder Xuan looked at her with wide eyes.

"Tell me more!" Long Yijun said in a somewhat demanding tone.

Elder Shan nodded and explained her encounter with Xiao Hua's voice that occurred when she got too clingy to Yuan.

"Qi manifestation... Indeed, only Spirit Grandmasters would be able to achieve such a feat..." Long Yijun pondered with a serious look on his face.

Even as a peak Spirit Master, he could barely use qi manifestation, much less make it stiff enough to hit someone with it.

"If this is really the case, we won't have to worry too much about Disciple Yuan's safety. However, we can't let our guard down even after learning this information. After all, we want to show this Spirit Grandmaster that we truly care about Disciple Yuan and his well-being."

"I agree." Elder Xuan nodded.

"Good, now let's talk about their rewards. How should the sect award them for their contribution? I think they deserve more than just some contribution points," Long Yijun said.

"How about we let them cultivate at the Dragon's Peak?" Elder Xuan suddenly suggested.

"The Dragon's Peak? That's very generous of you..." Elder Shan looked at him with wide eyes.

"Can I hear your reason for this, Elder Xuan?" Long Yijun did not refuse and asked for his reason instead.

"Simple. Disciple Yuan. I wouldn't have even thought about it if not for Disciple Yuan. However, with his talents, he'll definitely benefit greatly from the Dragon's Peak. Perhaps he'll even feel indebted to us afterward." Elder Xuan said.

"Hmmm..." Long Yijun closed his eyes to ponder.

A few moments later, he opened his eyes again and mumbled, "I'd originally planned on letting him enter the Dragon's Peak after the Mystic Realm and before the Dragon Temple, but if I let him go there before the event, it'll definitely increase our chances of obtaining a higher rank."

"The other Core Disciples won't be happy once they learn of this, especially since Disciple Yuan is still an Outer Court disciple." Elder Shan suddenly said.

"Hmmm... Good point. The Mystic Realm is only two weeks away, and I don't intend on having Disciple Yuan participate as an Outer Court disciple. Although this is a little bit earlier than scheduled, let's have Disciple Yuan take the Inner Court disciple examination next week." Long Yijun said.

Sometime later, Elder Xuan asked, "What about the matter with the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower? Have the participating sects sent their disciples yet?"

Long Yijun then said, "I was just about to talk about this. Yes, they have already sent their disciples here. We are waiting on just a couple more people to arrive before we begin, and they are expected to arrive tomorrow."

"I see..."

At the same time, after leaving the Sect Master's headquarters, Yuan returned to his own home with the others still following him.

"We should celebrate your victory at the Dragon Pavilion," Xuan Wuhan suddenly suggested to them.

"That's a great idea. The treat will be on me." Fei Yuyan nodded.

And then she continued, "Of course, I am only treating Disciple Yuan. The two of you can pay for your own food."

"How stingy," Xuan Wuhan snorted.

"Why should I spend my precious contribution points on you who did nothing for me other than giving me headaches? What did you do to deserve it?" Fei Yuyan sneered back without hesitation.

Sometime later, Yuan and the others made their way to the Dragon Pavilion.

The people there were ecstatic when they saw Fei Yuyan's pretty face at the Dragon Pavilion because they thought that she had finally decided to practice there again.

"Welcome back, Senior apprentice-sister Fei! The stage has been lonely without you lately. Thankfully, you're finally back." One of the workers there quickly approached them.

"Senior apprentice-sister Xuan and senior apprentice-sister Min as well—welcome to the Dragon Pavilion."

"I'm sorry, but I did not come here today to play the zither. I'm here to eat. Give me your best table," Fei Yuyan said to the disciple who ignored Yuan because he didn't think Yuan was with them at first.

"Oh... Is that so..." The disciple showed a disappointed look on his face after learning that Fei Yuyan was only there to eat.

"Anyway, please follow me."

Fei Yuyan and the others proceeded to follow him.

However, the disciple frowned when he noticed that Yuan was also following behind them, and he said in a somewhat cold voice, "Excuse me, Outer Court disciple. Unless you're with these seniors, please wait outside."

Yuan raised his eyebrows slightly, and he said, "I am with them."

"Eh?"

The disciple turned to look at the three beauties who now held a small frown on their faces, and it was at this moment that the disciple realized that he'd fucked up big time.

"I-I deeply apologize for the misunderstanding!" The disciple bowed to Yuan.

"Just bring us to our table." Fei Yuyan said.

"R-Right away!"

The disciple turned around and led them to their table shortly later.

"Please take your time looking at the menu, seniors. I have another table to attend to so I'll go look for a replacement now..."

The disciple then scurried away without returning, almost like he didn't dare to continue being around them after his mistake, and he went to find another worker there to serve them.

A few minutes later, a disciple with a familiar face, Chu Bo, who had served Yuan previously, appeared before them to take their orders.

Author's Note: This might come as a surprise but check out my new novel 'Inferior Cultivation System' if you like OP MC, smart MC, knowledgeable MC, Systems, and face-slapping. Don't worry, it won't affect my release rate for Cultivation Online.

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Chapter 217 - An Expensive Meal

"Welcome back to the Dragon Pavilion, senior disciples," Chu Bo greeted Yuan and the others the moment he'd arrived before looking at Yuan with admiration in his gaze.

After all, this is his first time seeing someone with so many top beauties at once, and they were even prominent beauties within the sect. One can only imagine how many people would be envious of Yuan's situation right now, as he had a beauty sitting close to him in almost every direction.

"Have you decided on what you'd like to eat?" Chu Bo asked them after his greeting.

Yuan nodded and spoke without even a shred of hesitation within his voice, "I want everything on the menu like last time."

"..."

Everybody there beside Chu Bo looked at Yuan with surprised expressions on their faces, almost like they couldn't believe what they'd just heard.

"I understand. What about the Senior Fairies? What would you like to eat today?" Chu Bo proceeded to ask the others, dumbfounding them even more.

Yuan had already ordered everything that was on the menu, why did he feel the need to ask them what they wanted to eat? It was almost as if he expected Yuan to eat all of the food he'd ordered by himself, which didn't sound very possible.

Seeing these beauty staring at him with questionable gazes, Chu Bo responded with a somewhat stiff smile on his face, "Senior apprentice-

brother Yuan has a big appetite, and he finished everything on the menu by himself the last time he was here, so I assumed that he'd be doing the same this time..."

"What? Is that true?" They turned to look at Yuan who quickly nodded his head without any shame on his face.

"Heavens... even my contribution points would be in danger if we come to the Dragon Pavilion more than once a month..." Fei Yuyan spoke in a joking voice.

"Anyways, since that's the case, I'll have..."

Fei Yuyan ordered her food next, followed by Xuan Wuhan and Min Li.

"Thank you. I shall notify the cooks right now," Chu Bo bowed to them before leaving the place.

Once they were alone again, Fei Yuyan turned to look at Yuan and said, "Not only did we win this zither competition, I'd even improved my own zither arts greatly, and this is all thanks to you, Disciple Yuan. This isn't much, but I'd like to thank you properly..."

She then reached into her robes before retrieving her disciple identification badge.

"Let me see yours."

Yuan didn't think much about it and retrieved his bronze disciple identification badge.

Fei Yuyan placed her own directly before Yuan's badge, and a few seconds later, she transferred some of her own contribution points to him.

[You have received 1,000 contribution points from Fei Yuyan]

"Are you sure? You really don't need to... I didn't join the competition because I wanted a reward from you," Yuan said to her.

"It's okay, really. It's the only thing I can do for you now, and I don't know how else I can express my gratitude," she responded.

Yuan nodded and accepted the contribution points.

'I should check out the place where I can use my contribution later and see what I can buy with my points...' Yuan thought to himself as he put away his badge.

A few moments later, Yuan suddenly retrieved the Soul Ensnaring Zither and said, "Why don't I play a few songs while we wait for our food?"

"That sounds great!" Xuan Wuhan immediately nodded.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan began playing the zither. However, he didn't play anything too extravagant. With that being said, even though he wasn't playing seriously, it was good enough to fool every disciple in the Dragon Pavilion, making them believe that it was Fei Yuyan who was playing.

Meanwhile, the three beauties sitting around him stared at him without blinking, looking like they'd been mesmerized by his performance.

Sometime later, once the food began arriving at the table, Yuan stored the zither and began eating his food, quickly shocking the ladies.

'How can so much food fit inside such a small body?' They couldn't help but ask themselves.

'He's really talented in everything he does... even eating...'

Sometime later, Yuan sighed in a satisfied manner, "That was a great meal."

"I can't believe it... You really finished every single plate..." Xuan Wuhan mumbled in a dazed voice, and she continued, "This makes me somewhat worried about that time you had dinner at my house... It was probably only enough to fill the gaps between your teeth..."

"What? Disciple Yuan had dinner at your house?" Fei Yuyan turned to look at her with wide eyes, surprised by her sudden reveal.

"That's right. We had dinner with my father there as well." Xuan Wuhan said with a somewhat smug look on her face.

"..."

Fei Yuyan was speechless.

"Anyway, here's my badge for the bill. This is my treat." Fei Yuyan then handed Chu Bo her badge.

"Eh? Does that include us? Even though you'd already said that you wouldn't treat us?" Xuan Wuhan asked her.

Fei Yuyan glanced at her and said, "I will gladly change my mind and make you pay for it if that's what I am understanding from your words."

Xuan Wuhan immediately turned around and began whistling. Although she has plenty of contribution points as well, she'd rather not use them if she didn't have to, as she was saving them up for a new cultivation technique.

"Thank you, Senior apprentice-sister Fei." Chu Bo said as he subtracted the bill from her contribution points.

'200 contribution points gone just like that...' Fei Yuyan's eyebrows uncontrollably twitched after seeing the devastation Yuan had caused to her wallet. For an ordinary disciple, it would take months, even years to collect 200 contribution points, yet she'd spent the same amount for a single meal, not to mention the 1,000 contribution points she'd given to Yuan beforehand.

Spending 1,200 contribution points in a single day, unless somebody went on a shopping spree in the Exchange Hall and bought every expensive treasure their gaze landed on, was an unthinkable act that would cause many disciples to physically cry.

Author's Note: Check out my new novel 'Inferior Cultivation System' if you like OP MC, smart MC, knowledgeable MC, Systems, and face-slapping. Don't worry, it won't affect my release rate for Cultivation Online or Dual Cultivation.

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Chapter 218 - Heaven Severing Zither Arts

After leaving the Dragon Pavilion, Xuan Wuhan and Fei Yuyan said their farewells to Yuan and Min Li.

"I have to get back to training, so I'll find another time to chat with you, Yuan. It has been a wonderful experience these past few days," Xuan Wuhan said to him.

"Now that the zither competition is over, I also have to return to my regular training schedule. Once again, thank you for everything, Disciple Yuan. I'll see you later," Fei Yuyan bowed to him before leaving.

"What are you going to do now that the competition is over?" Min Li asked him as they walked back to their houses together.

"I'll spend some time on the technique I'd gotten from the competition, and then I'll probably go to the place where I can spend some of my contribution points," said Yuan.

"The Exchange Hall? What are you trying to buy?"

"I don't know yet. Do you want to come as well?" Yuan asked her, as he was used to having her follow him around.

"N-No... I have already spent enough time without a sword in my hands. Just like the other two, I must get back to my training, or else I'll get scolded by my family when I show no improvements," she sighed.

"I see... I'll see you around, Disciple Min," Yuan said to her before entering his building.

After returning to his room, Yuan retrieved the Divine-grade treasure and the Divine-rank technique to inspect it.

[Frozen Jade Zither]

[Grade: Divine]

[Quality: Low]

[Mental Strength Requirement: 35,000]

[Soul Strength Requirement: 50,000]

[Description: Can create music notes that will freeze one's heart and soul]

"Heaven Severing Zither Arts... A single music note can split the heavens in half..."

"Xiao Hua, I know Divine-grade treasures cannot be used by those with insufficient cultivation, but does that apply to even instruments? I cannot imagine exploding to death because I pulled one of its strings," Yuan said out loud.

"No, Brother Yuan can play it, but you won't be able to utilize its full potential," Xiao Hua's voice resounded, and she continued, "It'll just be like playing an ordinary zither without injecting your spiritual energy into it."

"One can also wield a Divine-grade sword as a mortal, but without the cultivation to use it properly, the Divine-grade sword will only function as though it's an ordinary sword that's sharper and more durable than usual."

"I see... So I can still use this zither to play music normally, but I won't be able to produce special effects that can only be done when using spiritual energy. I think I get the gist of treasures in general." Yuan nodded as he pulled one of the strings on the Frozen Jade Zither.

A beautiful music note resounded in the room.

"Hmmm... It's pretty good sounding, but I still prefer the Soul Ensnaring Zither," he mumbled after the noise calmed.

After putting away the Frozen Jade Zither, Yuan turned his attention to the Divine-rank technique 'Heaven Severing Zither Arts' and began reading through it.

"What an interesting technique..."

Yuan mumbled to himself after reading through the entire content once. After pondering for a few minutes, he returned to the first page to reread it once again.

An hour later, a notification appeared before Yuan as he was absorbed in the technique.

[You have learned 'Heaven Severing Zither Artz']

[Heaven Severing Zither Arts]

[Rank: Divine]

[Description: A single music note to sever the heavens!]

"Hmm... This technique was much simpler than I'd anticipated, and I managed to learn it in an hour. Guess I can give this technique to Fei Yuyan tomorrow when I check out the Exchange Hall."

With that in mind, Yuan logged off for the day and cultivated in the real world while waiting for Yu Rou's return.

"Welcome back, Yu Rou," Yuan said out loud after hearing her footsteps entering his room.

"I'm back, brother! And congratulations! I heard that you'd achieved first place in the zither competition! Of course, I had already expected this outcome since it's a given that you would come first in a music competition, but still, congratulations!" Yu Rou said to him in a cheerful voice.

"Thank you, Yu Rou."

"I wish I was there to witness it... But alas... School... Haaa..." Yu Rou sighed.

"Don't worry, I'll play the zither for you the next time we meet," said Yuan.

"It won't be the same since you're not competing against others..."

"To be honest, it wasn't much of a competition since it was very different from what I'm used to."

Yuan spoke with Yu Rou for about half an hour, telling her everything he'd experienced at the competition before Yu Rou left the room and Yuan went to cultivate for the rest of the night.

Once morning came and Yu Rou finished her morning routine, Yuan dived back into Cultivation Online and left his house early in the morning to head to Fei Yuyan's house so he could give her the Divine-grade technique.

However, halfway there, Yuan suddenly stopped walking, as he'd realized that he no longer had the permission to enter the Inner Court, prohibiting him from even getting close to Fei Yuyan's living quarters, much less meet her.

'Looks like I'll have to find another way to meet her,' he thought to himself.

'For now, let's head to the Exchange Hall to see what kind of things they have there.'

Thus, Yuan turned around and began making his way towards the Exchange Hall after taking a moment to recall the map of the sect.

On his way to the Exchange Hall, Yuan passed the Practice Grounds, where hundreds of disciples were already awake and training. Of course, Min Li was also there, practicing her sword techniques on the training puppets and being watched by the other disciples, their gazes filled with admiration for Min Li.

Yuan stopped to watch Min Li practice for a few minutes before he continued walking again.

Half an hour later, he stood before a tall and large pagoda that had 3 floors, and directly above its entrance was a grand sign that read 'Exchange Hall'.

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Chapter 219 - Exchange Hall

"So this is the Exchange Hall, huh?" Yuan stared at the entrance with a pondering gaze.

The Exchange Hall is where disciples go to spend their hard-earned contributions points, and unlike the Profound Pavilion that only has cultivation techniques, the Exchange Hall has everything else from treasures to cultivation resources.

"Hey! Why are you standing there and blocking the entrance? If you're not going to enter, scram!"

A tall and bulky disciple suddenly walked up from behind and forcefully bumped into Yuan's shoulder, snapping him out of his admiration for the building.

Yuan frowned at this. He was standing many meters away from the entrance and was nowhere near it, so how could he be blocking the entrance.

"What? Do you have a problem?" The bulky disciple that rudely bumped into Yuan stopped walking when he noticed the displeased look on Yuan's handsome face, feeling even more irritated at Yuan because of his own lacking appearance.

This small commotion quickly attracted the disciples in that area.

"Look! Someone had offended Senior apprentice-disciple Tiger, the Mad Tiger!"

"What's this about? Why would an Outer Court disciple offend him? Does he not know who he's dealing with?"

"I don't know, but only an idiot would dare to offend one of the top ten disciples in the Outer Court! And this is Mad Tiger we're talking about! He's infamous for beating anyone that bothers him even slightly!"

While the disciples there watched the commotion from a distance and laughed at Yuan's misfortune, the bulky disciple who is known as 'Mad Tiger' approached Yuan in an aggressive manner.

Disciple Tiger stopped once he stood directly before Yuan and stared at Yuan in the eyes, and he said in an overbearing voice, "Since you don't seem to recognize me, I'll assume that you're a new disciple and give you some slack. I am Wu Laohu, ranked 3rd in the Outer Court ranking! Now that you know my identity, you can either kiss the ground with your forehead and apologize for blocking my way or eat one of my fists— you decide."

However, Yuan stood his ground despite the menacing aura coming from Disciple Tiger's large body that resembled a boulder, and he said in a calm voice, "I will choose neither. You were the one who bumped into me. If somebody has to apologize, it should be you."

"Heavens! He actually dared to defy Mad Tiger even after he had introduced himself! This Outer Court disciple is simply courting death!"

"Looks like another victim will fall to the Mad Tiger today..."

Wu Laohu's body trembled after hearing Yuan's words that defied him, and veins began appearing all over his body.

"Since you cannot pick— I shall pick one for you!" Wu Laohu suddenly raised his fists with an explosive aura.

However, just as Wu Laohu prepared to release his punch, a figure appeared behind him and gently tapped his shoulders, drifting Wu Laohu's attention to behind him.

"E-Elder Zhou!"

Wu Laohu's aggressive aura immediately disappeared when he saw the face of the person standing behind him, and his large figure suddenly appeared much smaller than just a moment ago.

"Just because you are ranked 3rd in the Outer Court ranking does not mean you can act however you please in this sect. This is also not the sparring stage but the Exchange Hall. If you continue causing a ruckus out here, I'll gladly be your opponent." Elder Zhou said to him.

"I-It was this disciple's mistake. It won't happen again, Elder Zhou!" Wu Laohu bowed to Elder Zhou in a respectful manner, yet his eyes remained on Yuan's figure.

'This is all that little bastard's fault! If he didn't oppose me, I wouldn't have been scolded by Elder Zhou in front of so many people! How fucking unlucky of me!' Wu Laohu cried inwardly, pushing all of the blame to Yuan.

"If you're here to purchase something, do your business and leave."

"Yes, Elder Zhou!" Wu Laohu did not dare to linger around and immediately went inside the Exchange Hall.

The other disciples there followed and immediately returned to their own business.

Elder Zhou then turned to look at Yuan, who was just calmly standing there.

'So this is Disciple Yuan, huh. I didn't get to see him last time at the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower because of the guests, but he's somewhat different from what I'd expected. He appears... more humble than I'd imagined...' Elder Zhou thought to himself.

"You too. If you have business at the Exchange Hall, do it and leave. This is not a place for you to loiter around," Elder Zhou said to Yuan a moment later.

Although he'd like to speak with Yuan more, he knew about Yuan's special existence, so he couldn't just start chatting with him as though they were friends, as that would immediately raise suspicions from the other disciples.

"Thank you, Elder, for stopping that disciple." Yuan bowed to him before entering the Exchange Hall.

'What a humble kid. But if I hadn't stopped that disciple just now, you would've sent him flying...' Elder Zhou sighed inwardly as he watched Yuan's figure disappearing into the building.

Once he'd entered the Exchange Hall, Yuan went directly to the reception desk and asked the disciple behind the counter, "Hello, what do you sell here?"

The disciple looked at Yuan as though he was looking at someone crazy, and he spoke a moment later, "This is the Exchange Hall. Whether it be cultivation resources or treasures, you can have anything you want as long as you have enough contribution points."

"Anything I want?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

However, he'd only come here to see what they had, even expecting some sort of display area like regular stores, so if he was asked what he wanted, he most likely wouldn't have an answer immediately.

'What do I need?' Yuan began pondering.

"If you don't know what you want yet, you can think about it elsewhere—just don't stand here." The disciple warned Yuan.

"Oh, okay." Yuan nodded and proceeded to stand in the corner of the large room, pondering if there was anything he needed from this place.

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Chapter 220 - The Most Unreasonable Person Yet

Standing casually by the wall, Yuan pondered what he could use his contribution points on.

'I already have two Soul Weapons and a couple of treasures, so I don't need any more of these. I also have enough techniques. What about cultivation resources? But how do I know what I need?'

'I am one level away from being a Spirit Master, but I am not in a rush. Though, if they have something that can help me reach Spirit Master, I might as well get it...'

After pondering for a few minutes, Yuan decided to ask for some Spirit Warrior monster cores so that he can consume them and hopefully reach the Spirit Master realm.

However, just as Yuan prepared to return to the reception, a large frame suddenly stepped in front of him and blocked his path.

Yuan raised his eyes slightly to look at Mad Tiger Wu Laohu staring at him with profound rage within his gaze.

"What do you want this time? I'm certain that I'm not blocking your path this time," Yuan said to him in a slightly mocking tone.

"You must think you're safe just because Elder Zhou stopped me from beating you, huh? Unless you plan on staying in the Exchange Hall for the rest of your life, you'll never escape from me!" Wu Laohu growled in a low voice.

"Why would I need to escape from you? If you have a problem with me, we can settle this with a sect elder's assistance." Yuan said to him.

"Oh, don't worry, we'll settle this alright, and we won't even need any assistance from a sect elder," said Wu Laohu as he reached into his robes and pulled out his disciple identification token.

"I, Wu Laohu, challenge you to a deathmatch!"

Ding!

[You have received a special request!]

[Outer Court Disciple Wu Laohu has challenged you to a deathmatch!]

The other disciples there gasped in shock when they heard Wu Laohu's words.

"Good lord! Did the Mad Tiger just challenge someone to a deathmatch?! It has been over a year since he's last stepped onto that kind of stage!"

"What's that Outer Court disciple going to do?! He has every right to refuse Mad Tiger's challenge, but I doubt the Mad Tiger would accept that!"

Yuan looked at Wu Laohu's disciple identification badge that was shoved directly in front of his face, and he spoke in a somewhat surprised voice, "You're willing to challenge someone to a deathmatch because they 'blocked' your path? You're probably the most unreasonable person I've come across to date!"

"You think this is about that?! This is about you making me lose face in front of so many people! This is about Elder Zhou scolding me! If you hadn't opposed me, none of that would've happened!" Wu Laohu said in a suppressed voice, yet one could hear the anger in his voice very clearly!

Yuan stared at Wu Laohu in disbelief. He simply couldn't believe that someone so unreasonable would exist in this world, and he cannot imagine what goes through such a mind.

After a moment of silence, Yuan shook his head and said, "I'll have to refuse your challenge. You may be an unreasonable person, but there's no reason for me to go along with your farce."

"Y-You little..." Wu Laohu's large body trembled, yet he didn't dare to act too rashly, especially since he was inside the Exchange Hall. If he fought Yuan in this place, he would definitely receive a harsh punishment. However, if he waited until Yuan left the premises, he would be able to beat Yuan up all he wanted and he'll most likely only receive a slap on the wrist like all the other times.

"Good! If that's how you want to play, I'll play your damn game!" Wu Laohu said to Yuan before leaving the Exchange Hall with large strides and heavy steps.

'What a bothersome disciple...' Elder Zhou sighed inwardly after watching this scene from somewhere inside the building.

'I should let the Sect Master know about this just in case anything really happens.'

After Wu Laohu left the scene, an upset voice resounded in Yuan's head, "Why didn't you just accept his challenge, Young Master? It wouldn't have required you to lift more than a single finger to kill that arrogant cultivator. If you don't want to kill him, I'll gladly turn him into ashes for you!"

Yuan shook his head and said, "I simply cannot imagine killing someone over something so insignificant. Why are there such unreasonable and petty people in this world? It's almost like nobody had taught them about decency or respect."

"Anyway, I'm going to see if they have Spirit Warrior monster cores. I really hope that guy calms." Yuan said as he approached the receptionist once again.

If Wu Laohu was a fellow player, he might've accepted the deathmatch because they can respawn with only slightly inconveniences, but since he doesn't know whether NPCs can respawn or not, he didn't want to take

their lives so easily, as that would feel like he'd actually murdered someone.

After reaching the desk, the disciple behind it looked at Yuan as though he was crazy, as most Outer Court disciples wouldn't even dare to look at Wu Laohu, much less oppose him!

"Do you have any Spirit Warrior monster cores?" Yuan asked the disciple since he wasn't talking.

"Spirit Warrior... monster cores?"

The ridicule on the disciple's face became even more apparent after hearing Yuan's words. After all, what kind of Outer Court disciple would be able to afford Spirit Warrior monster cores? Even if he could afford it, why would he need something so powerful at his level? Only Core Disciples would need something so powerful.

"You won't find any Spirit Warrior monster cores on the first floor. You need to head to the second floor, but only Inner Court disciples are allowed up there." The disciple answered Yuan a moment later.

"Inner Court disciple, huh? Looks like I won't be able to obtain the monster cores for now." Yuan sighed.

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Chapter 221 - Disciples From Other Sects

After Yuan left the Exchange Hall because he learned that one cannot access the second floor unless they are Inner Court disciples, he suddenly recalled the silver medallion that Elder Xuan had given him.

'If I remember correctly, the silver medallion will allow me to obtain cultivation resources at the Treasury Hall. Maybe they'll have some Spirit Warrior monster cores there.' Yuan thought to himself.

'Where's the Treasury Hall, again?' Yuan began pondering.

A few moments later, once Yuan realized that the Treasury Hall was in the Inner Court, he sighed out loud, "In the end, I still have to become an Inner Court disciple..."

"What should I do now?"

Yuan looked around the sect with a pondering look, wondering where he should explore now that his adventure had ended much quicker than he'd expected.

And just as he was thinking, Yuan suddenly heard the disciples around him speaking with excitement, "Did you hear? Disciples from other sects are currently challenging the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower!"

"What? This is the first time outsiders are challenging the tower!"

"No, I think this has happened before, but that was very long ago. Why are disciples from other sects challenging the tower so suddenly? Did something happen recently?"

"You forgot already? One of our disciples had managed to clear all one hundred floors, creating a pretty big commotion not long ago!"

"Oh, right, that did happen, and we still don't know that disciple's identity. However, what does that have anything to do with what's happening now?"

"Who cares! Do you want to go watch or not?"

"Of course! Let's go!"

Many disciples from around the sect could be seen approaching the same direction at this moment— towards the Carp Leaping of Dragon's Gate Tower to witness the special event.

Yuan's interest was immediately piqued after listening to the disciples, mostly by the disciples from the other sects, and he began following the other disciples to the scene.

Sometime later, Yuan arrived at the Carp Leaping of Dragon's Gate Tower where hundreds of other disciples and even sect elders were already present.

'Wow, there's a lot of people here...' Yuan thought to himself as he stood towards the end of the crowd, so he couldn't really see the disciples from the other sects.

However, he was able to see the golden lights emitted by the tower, and whoever was challenging the tower at this moment was on the 40th floor.

"Heavens! Who's currently inside the tower?" One of the newcomers there decided to ask.

"It's Ao Zongqing that's inside right now. It took him less than an hour to reach 40 floors." Someone there responded.

"What! The number one genius from the Iron Courage Pavilion?! Why's he challenging the tower?!"

"Nobody really knows the details, but rumors say it's because of a gamble between the Dragon Essence Temple and their sect."

Meanwhile, standing in the front, there were seven disciples and four sect masters from their respective sects. Of course, Long Yijun and some of the high-ranking sect elders were there as well.

'It would be nice if we could see what's happening inside, but alas...'

Yuan wanted to watch the disciples from the other sects challenge the tower, but then he remembered how long it took Min Li to finish, which quickly made him lose interest, as he wasn't willing to stand around for a whole week until they all finish.

Thus, after standing around for a couple of minutes, Yuan decided to leave the place and return to his own room.

However, right as he turned around and walked a few steps, Elder Xuan's voice resounded in his head, "Disciple Yuan, go to the Inner Court and find Elder Shan. She has a few things to give you and also something to tell you. If you need help entering the Inner Court, show the elder your gold disciple identification badge."

Yuan nodded and began making his way towards the Inner Court whilst Elder Xuan remained at the tower for the event.

'I didn't know I could use my second identification badge like this... Now I can visit the Treasury Hall as well.' Yuan thought to himself.

Many minutes later, Yuan arrived at the entrance to the Inner Court.

"What do you want, Outer Court disciple? Do you have business in the Inner Court?" The elder there asked Yuan.

"Yes. Here's my identification badge." Yuan responded as he showed the elder his gold identification badge.

"T-This is...!" The sect elder was immediately shocked to see the gold identification token, and he turned to look at Yuan with wide eyes filled

with disbelief and respect.

"I understand... If you don't mind me asking, what business do you have in the Inner Court?" The elder asked him after handing the badge back to him.

"I would like to go to the Treasury Hall," Yuan answered, purposefully not mentioning Elder Shan.

"Thank you... You may enter now." The sect elder then opened the gates for him, allowing Yuan to enter the Inner Court with relatively no effort.

Yuan was slightly dumbfounded by how easy it was to enter the Inner Court.

'This gold identification badge is very convenient...' Yuan thought to himself as he stored the badge inside the spatial ring.

'If I recall correctly, Elder Shan said that I could find her at the Blossom Peak...' Yuan closed his eyes and opened the sect's map inside his head to look for a Blossom Peak.

Once he'd located Blossom Peak, Yuan began making his way towards Elder Shan's place, even passing the Treasury Hall on the way there.

About half an hour later, Yuan arrived at this vast and spacious hill with a single large building sitting in the middle and surrounded by a flower field.

And even though he was still very far away from Elder Shan's building, he could see Elder Shan's figure and a couple of other figures near a blossom tree right beside the house, looking like they were in a lecture or something.

Seeing this, Yuan began walking towards them with a nonchalant look on his face.

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Chapter 222 - Elder Shans Reward

Chapter 222 - Elder Shan's Reward

As Yuan approached Elder Shan and the other two figures, he noticed these four-legged objects sitting on the ground in front of them, and they were pretty large as well.

'What are those things? They look like pots... And there is even smoke coming from them...' Yuan thought to himself as he got closer and closer to them.

"Senior Shan!" Yuan called out to her once he was close enough.

"Hmm?" Elder Shan turned around with raised eyebrows, wondering who would dare to enter her territory without making an appointment, as she wasn't expecting any visitors today.

However, when she saw Yuan's innocent face, a smile immediately appeared on her face, and she said, "Disciple Yuan! You've arrived much quicker than I'd anticipated. I wasn't expecting to see you until tomorrow, after all."

The other two figures also turned to look at Yuan after they saw Elder Shan's reaction, acting like she was delighted to see him or something.

'An Outer Court disciple...?'

These two disciples raised their eyebrows after seeing Yuan's uniform, as they have never seen an Outer Court disciple appearing in this sacred place before.

"Hello, Senior Shan. I hope I'm not bothering you, but Senior Xuan told me to come here," Yuan said to her.

"Don't worry, you won't bother me even if you tried!" Elder Shan laughed gracefully before she pointed to the two dumbfounded figures sitting not far away from her.

"Let me introduce you to my disciples."

Elder Shan's disciples then stood up and introduced themselves despite feeling that Yuan should've been the first one to introduce himself since they were more senior.

"Qian Qi, Inner Court disciple."

"Bei Bei, Core Disciple."

They gave a simple and direct introduction.

Yuan nodded and said, "Hello, I am Yuan."

After their brief introduction, Elder Shan turned to look at her disciples and said, "Anyway, the two of you can continue concocting pills. I'll be right back."

"Follow me inside," Elder Shan said to him before entering the building.

Yuan nodded and followed her.

Once they were inside, Elder Shan pointed to the couch and said, "Go ahead. Take a seat."

After Yuan sat down on the couch, Elder Shan also took a seat, even deciding to sit directly beside him.

"First and foremost, allow me to congratulate you again for getting first place in the zither competition, exceeding my expectations." Elder Shan said to him with a somewhat serious look on her face, and she continued, "Even though you've already received a reward from the competition, the Dragon Essence Temple has decided to also reward you for your contribution since your results greatly increased our reputation."

"Let me see your identification badge."

Yuan nodded and showed her his bronze identification badge.

[You have received 10,000 contribution points from Shan Shang]

"Ten thousand contribution points!" Yuan mumbled in a surprised voice.

"10,000 contribution points may be a lot, but compared to the next reward, it's almost worthless," Elder Shan said with a smile on her face.

"There are more rewards?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

Elder Shan nodded and said, "The Sect Master has decided to let you go to the Dragon's Peak."

"Dragon's Peak? What's that?" Yuan asked.

"It's one of the most sacred places in the Dragon Essence Temple beside the Dragon Temple. After all, it used to be our Ancestor's peak."

"What's so special about this place?" Yuan continued to ask.

"Well, I have only been there once, but the spiritual energy there is extremely dense for some reason, which will greatly boost your cultivation speed. Furthermore, legend has it that the Ancestor had hidden a treasure in that place before he disappeared, but nobody has been able to find it despite looking through every nook and cranny."

"I see..."

"One more thing, we want you to participate in the Inner Court disciple examination next week and become an Inner Court disciple," said Elder Shan after a moment of silence.

"Eh? Inner Court disciple? I thought we can only do that once we've spent enough time as an Outer Court disciple."

"Indeed, but there are always special occasions. As long as you have the Sect Master's permission, a disciple can partake in the Inner Court— even Core Disciple examination regardless of their time in the sect."

After a moment of silence, Yuan nodded, "Okay. If the Sect Master wants me to become an Inner Court disciple, I'll participate in the examination."

"Thank you, Disciple Yuan. Once you become an Inner Court disciple, you'll be able to enter the Dragon's Peak. After Dragon's Peak will be the start of the Mystic Realm, so you'll be quite busy."

"It'll be a great experience," Yuan said with a smile.

"Do you have anything else for me?" He then asked.

"No, that's all for now." Elder Shan said.

"Then I won't linger around and disturb your lecture with your disciples."

"Don't worry about it. I am only going through previous lessons today."

"I'll see you later, Senior Shan," Yuan said as he stood up.

"Wait a second."

Elder Shan suddenly grabbed his robes.

"Hmm?"

Just as Yuan turned around, Elder Shan stood up and moved with lightning-quick speed, giving him a gentle kiss on the forehead.

"E-Elder Shan?" Yuan stared at her with a dumbfounded look on his face.

"That was my reward to you. I'll give you something even more intense if you manage to achieve first place for the Mystic Realm as well." Elder Shan winked at him with a smile on her beautiful face.

Yuan was speechless and didn't know how he should respond to such words. Therefore, he only nodded at her words in a dazed manner.

Meanwhile, Xiao Hua nearly left the necklace on an impulse after seeing Elder Shan's quick and sly action, but she'd somehow managed to resist herself and remained inside the necklace.

Sometime later, Yuan left Elder Shan's house, but right as he closed the door, he could hear a painful cry suddenly coming from Elder Shan.

Bonk! Bonk! Bonk!

"Ah!"

"Are you okay?" Yuan asked her, who was almost in tears from the pain.

"Y-Yes... I am..." Elder Shan said with a stiff smile on her face.

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Chapter 223 - I Did Not Steal Anything!

"Goodbye, fellow disciples," Yuan said to Elder Shan's disciples before leaving the premises.

The two disciples watched as Yuan's figure disappeared into the distance, and they mumbled—

"Just who is that Outer Court disciple? What relationship does he have with our Master?" Qian Qi asked out loud.

"I have never seen him before so I don't know. But if he can come to this place as an Outer Court disciple then there must be something special about him. Maybe he's from a powerful family," said Bei Bei the Core Disciple.

A couple of minutes later, once the pain dealt by Xiao Hua had finally disappeared, Elder Shan came back outside and returned to their lectures.

When her disciples saw this, they wondered if she would tell them about that mysterious Outer Court disciple later, but alas, Elder Shan never mentioned Yuan even after their lecture ended.

After leaving Elder Shan's place, Yuan began making his way towards the Treasury Hall, but then he recalled something that made him turn around and walk in another direction.

Sometime later, Yuan arrived at a familiar-looking place— Fei Yuyan's living quarters.

Yuan approached the doorstep and knocked on her door.

After waiting for a couple of moments without any answer, Yuan knocked on the door again, and he repeated this for a few minutes.

"Is she not home?" Yuan mumbled.

Yuan decided to wait a few more minutes just in case Fei Yuyan was busy.

Once he was certain that Fei Yuyan was absent, Yuan decided to leave for now and head to the Treasury Hall.

"I'll just come back here at another time since I can enter the Inner Court without any problems now."

After leaving Fei Yuyan's living quarters, Yuan finally arrived at the Treasury Hall half an hour later, and although it resembled the Exchange Hall, there was only a single floor here.

Upon entering the building, Yuan went straight to the front desk where a sect elder was in charge.

The sect elder turned to look at Yuan with raised eyebrows after seeing his Outer Court uniform.

"What's an Outer Court disciple like you doing here? Only Inner Court disciples are allowed to use this place, you know." The sect elder said to him.

Hearing the sect elder's question, Yuan retrieved his spatial ring and took out the silver medallion that Elder Xuan had given to him before showing it to the sect elder behind the desk.

"Can I use this place if I have this?" Yuan asked him in a calm voice.

"What's that?"

The sect elder did not immediately recognize the silver medallion at first because it was so rare. However, once he picked it up and inspected it, his eyes widened with shock, and he exclaimed, "T-The Silver Fortune Medallion! Where'd you get this?!" The sect elder exclaimed in a startled

voice, sounding as though he'd just witnessed his ancestors crawling out of their graves.

"Uhh... It was given to me?" Yuan said.

"Nonsense! There's no way an Outer Court disciple would have something like this! You either stole it or found it by accident! I am confiscating this now!" The elder said with a frown on his face as he tossed the Silver Fortune Medallion inside his pocket.

"What?!" Yuan exclaimed in a surprised manner, and he spoke, "How could you accuse me of stealing it when you have no proof! It was given to me! You can't just take it from me!"

"Hmph! Do I need any proof besides you being an Outer Court disciple?"

"What does my disciple status have anything to do with this?" Yuan asked with a frown.

"Then let me ask you this— What kind of Outer Court disciple would have the Silver Fortune Medallion that allows one to retrieve as many treasures as they want from the Treasury Hall?! Not even Core Disciples would be given such a thing, let alone an Outer Court disciple!" The sect elder responded. After all, if the sect were to give an Outer Court disciple the Silver Fortune Medallion that allows them near full access to the Treasury Hall, they might as well make him a high-ranking sect elder!

"But it is a fact that I was given that medallion! Please give it back to me." Yuan extended his hand with a stern look on his face.

"The audacity! I am already saving you some face by not giving you a beating for stealing such a precious thing! If you don't scram, I'll not only discipline you but also report you to the Sect Master!" The sect elder raised his voice, causing the other people there to notice them.

"Stealing? Did that Outer Court disciple steal something from the Treasury Hall? Does he have a death wish?"

"What kind of idiot would try to steal from the sect..."

The Inner Court disciples there shook their heads before returning to their own business, as they couldn't care less about an Outer Court disciple who was about to be punished.

"Well?! Do you admit to stealing the Silver Fortune Medallion or not?!"
The sect elder then said, urging Yuan to admit his faults.

"I did not steal anything!"

However, Yuan did not back down and refused to admit to something he didn't do.

Seeing this, the sect elder trembled in anger, and he suddenly pulled his arms back before releasing it, propelling his palms at Yuan with a powerful force.

"Get out of here!" The sect elder said as he attacked Yuan, trying to kick him outside with force.

Yuan's eyes widened with surprise when the sect elder attacked him out of nowhere. Though, since the sect elder was only a sixth-level Spirit Warrior, Yuan did not feel intimidated or pressured.

Just as the sect elder's palms reached Yuan's chest, Yuan activated his movement technique and dodged the strike flawlessly.

The sect elder's eyes widened with surprise when Yuan dodged his surprise attack, and he could feel many surprised gazes directed at him, which caused his face to flush with redness.

"Y-You little brat...!" The sect elder growled in a low voice, feeling like Yuan had slapped him in the face by dodging his strike in front of so many people.

Chapter 224 - Treasury Hall

"W-What's going on?! Why did the sect elder suddenly attack that Outer Court disciple?!"

The Inner Court disciples there were greatly shocked by this sudden incident, as they have never seen such a forceful and aggressive reaction in the Treasury Hall before.

"Whatever that disciple did, he's done for. Nobody offends a sect elder from the Treasury Hall and gets away with it!"

"It's been a long time since someone has caused trouble in the Treasury Hall! I cannot wait to see how that Outer Court disciple gets punished!"

Meanwhile, Yuan turned to look at the sect elder with a frown on his face, "That was dangerous! How could you suddenly attack a disciple without any reason as a sect elder?!"

"Without a reason?! I have plenty of reasons to discipline you! You not only stole the Silver Fortune Medallion but you also dared to talk back to a sect elder!"

"You assumed that I'd stolen it without any evidence, and then you attacked me when I asked for you to return it to me! That's unreasonable!"

"Shut your damn mouth, you freaking liar! How could a disciple like you exist in the righteous Dragon Essence Temple?! You don't belong here! Not only will I discipline you, but I will also make sure you are no longer a disciple after today!"

"I can say the same thing to you! You want to discipline me? Go ahead and try!" Yuan stood his ground, not willing to be bullied by the sect elder.

'Not only the disciples but even the sect elders are unreasonable! This really makes me question some things!' Yuan sighed inwardly.

Hearing Yuan's provoking words, the sect elder jumped over the desk and approached Yuan while surrounded by an aggressive aura.

"If I don't punish you today, I do not deserve to be a sect elder!" The sect elder spoke as he approached Yuan.

"Haaa... What the heck is going on here, Elder Gu? I stepped away for a few minutes and trusted you with the Treasury Hall, and this is how you repay me? By creating a commotion with an Outer Court disciple inside the Treasury Hall?" A sighing voice suddenly resounded, causing everybody there to look at the entrance, where a tall middle-aged man stood.

"Elder Bei!" Elder Gu looked at Elder Bei with a perplexed look on his face.

"You've misunderstood the situation, Elder Bei. I am merely disciplining this disciple who not only dared to steal a precious item from the sect but also dared to lie in front of a sect elder!"

Elder Bei raised his eyebrows, and he turned to look at Yuan, who was standing there still with an unpleasant look on his face.

"What did he steal?" Elder Bei asked as he approached them.

"This— the Silver Fortune Medallion!" Elder Gu quickly showed him the silver medallion in his hands.

"T-That's..." Elder Bei's eyes widened with shock when he saw the Silver Fortune Medallion.

He then turned to look at Yuan in a stiff motion before asking him, "Y-Young disciple... Can you tell me your name?"

"Disciple Yuan," he responded.

'Disciple Yuan! Shit! He's the disciple Grand Elder Xuan warned me about! This fucking idiot Elder Gu actually offended the one person we're not supposed to offend when I went to get some food!'

Elder Bei immediately began sweating after realizing the situation.

While Elder Xuan had told Elder Bei about Yuan and the Silver Fortune Medallion because he was the manager at this place, Elder Xuan didn't tell anyone else because he didn't want too many people knowing about Yuan's existence to keep the risks of revealing his identity low. Furthermore, Elder Gu was only an assistant working in this place temporarily, so he was definitely not briefed about Yuan.

But alas, little did Elder Xuan and Elder Bei expect that Yuan would arrive at the Treasury Hall at the worst time— when Elder Bei went out to get some food.

"Elder Bei?" Elder Gu called out to him when he stood there in silence for many moments.

Elder Bei rubbed his eyes and released a long sigh.

After sighing, he turned to look at the other disciples there and said, "The Treasury Hall is closed for today. Everybody, get out."

Although Elder Bei tried his best to remain calm, his voice turned out quite angry-sounding, causing the Inner Court disciples there to sweat.

The disciples began leaving the building, and a couple of moments later, only Elder Gu, a few other sect elders working there, and Yuan remained.

Once the place was dead silent, Elder Bei extended his hand at Elder Gu and spoke again, "Give me the Silver Fortune Medallion."

Elder Gu did not think twice and handed the silver medallion to Elder Bei.

Once the medallion was in his hands, Elder Bei turned to look at Yuan before showing him the Silver Fortune Medallion on his palm, almost like he was offering it to Yuan, shocking everybody there.

"I deeply apologize for the misunderstanding and inconvenience you've experienced at the Treasury Hall today. I am the only one here who was informed by Elder Xuan regarding your situation, so please excuse the others for their ignorance." Elder Bei lowered his head as he apologized to Yuan, shocking the others even more.

Yuan then said, "I won't blame anyone for being ignorant. However, being ignorant and being unreasonable are two different things. That sect elder immediately assumed that I'd stolen this medallion without any evidence when I showed it to him, even striking me out of the blue when I asked for him to return it. That's simply inexcusable."

"What? Is this true? He attacked you?" Elder Bei looked at Yuan with wide eyes.

Yuan nodded with a serious look on his face.

"..."

After a moment of silence, Elder Bei turned to look at Elder Gu and said, "Since when do we, sect elders, attack disciples over suspicions and without any evidence that they'd committed a crime? Even if he did, when did that become our responsibility to discipline disciples? The disciplinary squad exists for a reason! I will listen to the whole story and deal with you later. Go wait in my room until I am done here!"

"Y-Yes..." Elder Gu nodded with a dazed look on his face, as he still couldn't comprehend the situation. Why did Elder Bei protect that Outer Court disciple? Why was he scolded? It didn't make sense!

Once Elder Gu left the scene, Elder Bei returned to Yuan and said, "Don't worry, I will handle this properly later, so let's stop thinking about this for now. Why did you come to the Treasury Hall today? Are you looking for some treasure? Tell me what you need and I'll see if we have it."

Seeing how Elder Bei wanted to drop the subject, Yuan had no reason to continue this drama and said, "I am here to see if I can get some Spirit Warrior monster cores."

"Spirit Warrior monster cores?" Elder Bei raised his eyebrows at this unexpected answer.

"Do you have a specific type of monster core in mind?"

Yuan shook his head and replied, "No, any kind of monster core will do."

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Chapter 225 - Ill Take Them All

Chapter 225 - I'll Take Them All

"Any kind, huh?" Elder Bei went behind the desk and took out a small book that listed all of the monster cores they had in the Treasury Hall. While they have plenty of Spirit Apprentice monster cores, they don't have many monster cores at the Spirit Warrior level since it's not often sought after by the disciples.

"How many do you need? And what level do you prefer for the Spirit Warrior monster cores?"

Yuan scratched his head and said, "Honestly, I don't know how many I need, but I'd like the highest level monster core you have."

"The highest level?" Elder Bei looked at him with wide eyes.

In his eyes, Yuan was only at the ninth level Spirit Apprentice realm. Why would he need monster cores that were far above his own level?

However, since the Treasury Hall has wronged Yuan, Elder Bei didn't ask him any questions and looked at the monster core book.

A few moments later, he said, "The highest level Spirit Warrior monster core we have right now is at the 8th level, and we only have one of them. We also have one 6th level Spirit Warrior monster core. Then we have about a dozen Spirit Warrior monster cores below the 3rd level."

"I'll take them all," Yuan said without any hesitation.

"A-All of them?" Elder Bei looked at Yuan with a gawking expression on his face, wondering if this is Yuan's method of revenge because they'd treated him wrongly.

However, since Yuan had the Silver Fortune Medallion, the Treasury Hall was obligated to give Yuan whatever he wanted as long as it wasn't unreasonable. While the monster cores are worth a couple of hundred contribution points, it wasn't so much that it would instantly bankrupt the Treasury Hall.

After a moment of silence, Elder Bei nodded with a forced smile on his face, "I understand. Please give me a minute to prepare your monster cores."

Yuan nodded and proceeded to wait whilst the other sect elders watched him with dazed expressions.

A couple of minutes later, Elder Bei returned to the room with a large box.

"Here are your monster cores." Elder Bei placed the box on the counter.

Yuan nodded and then said, "Thank you. How many contribution points do I have to pay for it?"

"Pay?" Elder Bei looked at him with raised eyebrows before saying, "You don't have to pay anything. It's all for free."

Yuan looked at him with wide eyes and mumbled, "Free?"

In his mind, the Silver Fortune Medallion only gave him access to the Treasury Hall and perhaps some low tier treasures for free, but he didn't expect that it would allow him to obtain so many Spirit Warrior monster cores for free, as that sounded too good to be true in a place where most disciples are expected to earn their resources.

"Uhh... I'll feel bad if I accept so many resources for free. How about I purchase them at a discounted rate instead?" Yuan suddenly suggested.

Since he already has so many contribution points, it would be a waste if he didn't use them because he would get everything for free.

After pondering for a moment, Elder Bei nodded, "Since you insist on paying for them, I'll give you a 50% discount for the monster cores. It'll be

450 contribution points. Are you okay with this?"

Yuan nodded and handed Elder Bei his disciple identification badge without hesitation.

A few moments later, Elder Bei handed Yuan's identification badge back to him and said, "Thank you for your business."

Yuan accepted his badge and the monster cores, tossing them into his spatial ring afterward.

Once he had everything he needed, Yuan left the Treasury Hall with a calm look on his face and made his way back to his own living quarters.

Meanwhile, Elder Bei turned to look at the other sect elders and said, "What happened here today... You will act as though it never happened, or you can ignore what I said and risk your status as a sect elder. That's all I have to say."

After his brief words that shocked the other sect elders, Elder Bei returned to his room in the Treasury Hall where Elder Gu was waiting.

"E-Elder Bei! What was that all about?! Why did you protect that Outer Court disciple?!" Elder Gu immediately began asking for an explanation.

"..."

In response to Elder Gu's words, Elder Bei raised his hands and swung them directly across Elder Gu's face, slapping him soundly.

"Y-You..." Elder Gu looked at Elder Bei with disbelief in his eyes and a burning sensation on his cheeks, but he didn't dare to retaliate since he was far weaker than Elder Bei who was at the Spirit Master realm.

"Follow me!"

Elder Bei said and turned around, walking outside.

Although he was reluctant, Elder Gu couldn't oppose Elder Bei's commands and followed him outside.

Once they were outside alongside the other sect elders, Elder Bei asked out loud, "Allow me to ask all of you this— What did I tell all of you at the beginning of this month?"

One of the sect elders there immediately raised his hand and said, "That if a disciple with the Silver Fortune Medallion appears, we are to immediately notify you, Elder Bei!"

"Good! So I wasn't just dreaming about telling you!" Elder Bei then turned to look at Elder Gu and asked them, "Then what happened to you, Elder Gu? Did you forget? Or did you purposefully disobey my order?"

"I-I had forgotten, Elder Bei..." Elder Gu quickly responded.

"I see, so you'd forgotten, huh? Then let's hope this incident will help you remember things better in the future." Elder Bei said, and he continued after taking a deep breath, "Regardless of how the entire situation went down, even if I want to, I cannot protect you since you decided to attack that disciple."

"However, I do not have the authority to punish you since I am only the manager of this place, so I will let someone with more authority and status than myself handle you. Elder Gu, you are temporarily relieved of your duties in the Treasury Hall, and I will be letting Grand Elder Xuan know about the situation so he can deal with you later."

"G-Grand Elder Xuan?!" Elder Gu exclaimed in a shocked voice. Why would a Grand Elder be involved in such a minor incident?!

Chapter 226 - You Cannot Do This To Me!

"W-Why do you have to involve Grand Elder Xuan?! This is only a small incident! There's no need to bother a grand elder because of an Outer Court disciple! That's an exaggeration, Elder Bei!" Elder Gu immediately began sweating after hearing that Grand Elder Xuan might be involved in this mess.

Elder Bei shook his head before sighing, "You really are clueless, aren't you, Elder Gu? Just an Outer Court disciple? Do you really think an ordinary Outer Court disciple will be given the Silver Fortune Medallion? When was the last time an Outer Court disciple had such a priceless object in their pockets? Think about it before you speak..."

Elder Gu immediately turned speechless. After listening to Elder Bei's words, he'd finally come to that realization, but alas, it was too late for him to regret it, as there was no medicine for regret in this world.

"Get out of my sight before I lose my patience." Elder Bei said a few seconds later.

Elder Gu nodded in a dispirited manner before walking out of the Treasury Hall and returning to his living quarters, where he pondered what he went wrong and what he could've done to prevent this disaster that had fallen upon him.

Meanwhile, Elder Bei returned to his room and retrieved a communication jade slip.

After activating it with his spiritual energy, Elder Bei spoke to it, "Grand Elder Xuan, this is Elder Bei from the Treasury Hall. I apologize for bothering you, but this is regarding Disciple Yuan that you'd warned me about..."

Elder Bei proceeded to explain the situation to Grand Elder Xuan, telling him about Elder Gu's behavior and how he'd treated Yuan.

On the other side of the sect at the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate, Elder Xuan who'd been watching the disciples from the other sect challenge the tower immediately frowned after receiving Elder Bei's notice.

"Sect Master, I'll have to excuse myself for a bit." Elder Xuan said to him, who was also there with him.

"Hm? What happened?" Long Yijun raised his eyebrows after seeing Elder Xuan's angry face.

"Well..."

Elder Xuan proceeded to give a brief explanation of the situation about what had occurred at the Treasury Hall with Yuan and Elder Gu.

"Elder Gu did what?!" Long Yijun exclaimed in a shocked voice after hearing the news, causing the other people there to turn and look at him with raised eyebrows, wondering what this was about.

"Go deal with him quickly! If not for my current situation, I would personally see him myself!" Long Yijun said in an angry voice.

How could a sect elder treat Yuan in such a manner after his massive contribution to the sect? Granted that nobody in the sect knows about Yuan participating in the sect because Long Yijun had personally made it so that it wouldn't spread, there are no excuses for a sect elder to be acting like the way Elder Gu had towards any disciple.

A few moments later, Elder Xuan left the scene and headed towards the Inner Court and the Treasury Hall.

"Greetings, Grand Elder!"

The sect elders inside the Treasury Hall greeted Elder Xuan the moment he stepped into their building, feeling their back soaked in cold sweats, as they didn't expect Elder Xuan to appear so quickly.

"Tell me everything that happened." Elder Xuan spoke in a calm yet commanding voice.

One by one, the sect elders gave their side of the story and what they saw during the incident.

"I understand. Thank you."

After getting all of the sect elders' statements, Elder Xuan made his way to Elder Gu's living quarters and knocked on the door in a somewhat aggressive manner.

A few moments later, Elder Gu opened the door and appeared before Elder Xuan, greeting Elder Xuan with a pale complexion and his back soaked in sweat.

"Do you know why I am here?" Elder Xuan asked him with narrowed eyes.

"I...I do..." Elder Gu nodded in a timid manner.

"Before I say anything, I'll give you an opportunity to explain yourself and tell me your side of the story," said Elder Xuan.

"Thank you, Grand Elder!"

Elder Gu proceeded to explain the situation to him and how he thought Yuan had stolen the Silver Fortune Medallion because it wasn't possible for an Outer Court disciple to have such a thing.

However, Elder Gu also subtly blamed Yuan for being aggressive and disrespectful to him, hence why he lost his temper and tried to force him out of the Treasury Hall.

Elder Xuan's eyebrows twitched when Elder Gu called Yuan disrespectful and aggressive. Although he didn't say anything, Elder Xuan didn't believe even for a second that Yuan, who was as innocent as a child, would behave in such a manner without any reason.

A few minutes later, once Elder Gu finished explaining himself, Elder Xuan spoke in a low but grim voice, "You claimed that Disciple Yuan had disrespected you and even provoked you to attack him, but I cannot imagine someone like him doing such a thing. Although I may not have known him for long, I have known him long enough to know what kind of person he is."

"As for the Silver Fortune Medallion, Elder Bei had already warned everyone in the building about it, so you can only blame yourself for forgetting about it."

"Elder Gu, your behavior today has greatly disappointed the Sect Master and me. Therefore, as of this moment, you are no longer a disciple of the Dragon Essence Temple."

"W-What?! You're going to kick me out of the sect over a small mistake?! Because of a mere Outer Court disciple?! This isn't fair at all and totally not justified! It's not like I'd broken any sect rules either! You cannot do this to me, Grand Elder!" Elder Gu couldn't believe his ears.

However, Elder Xuan shook his head and said, "You have no idea who that 'Outer Court disciple' is, nor do you have any idea how much the sect values his presence. If you'd chased him out of the sect, even a million of your lives would not be able to compensate for such a loss!"

Chapter 227 - Nearly Lost Her Mind From Shock

"Even a million of my lives cannot compare to that Outer Court disciple's...?" Elder Gu stared at Elder Xuan with a dazed look on his face, his gaze filled with disbelief.

Elder Xuan shook his head and said, "You're extremely lucky that I was the one who came here since the Sect Master wanted to personally come here after hearing what you'd done. Fortunately for you, he's currently busy with our guests. If you understand what I'm saying, I recommend you leave this sect before the guests leave and the Sect Master comes to find you."

Elder Gu immediately began sweating again. The Sect Master wanted to see him? Because he'd offended a mere Outer Court disciple? Heavens! He better get as far away from the Dragon Essence Temple or else the Sect Master might skin him alive!

"If you don't have anything else to say, hand over your disciple identification badge." Elder Xuan said as he showed his palms to Elder Gu.

After a deep sigh, Elder Gu handed over his disciple identification badge.

"You have three days to pack everything and leave the sect's premises." Elder Xuan said to him before turning around and walking away, returning to the Long Yijun's side.

As for Elder Gu, since he didn't have much to pack, he left the Dragon Essence Temple without speaking to anyone, as he was too embarrassed by his own situation to say anything.

"Sect Master, everything has been dealt with."

After returning to Long Yijun's side, Elder Xuan showed him Elder Gu's disciple identification badge.

"Hmph! You're too kind, Elder Xuan. If it was me, I'd given him a good beating before I kicked him out!" Long Yijun coldly sneered before focusing on the tower again.

Meanwhile, inside his own room, Yuan retrieved the monster cores and laid them on the table.

After counting them, he had one 8th and 6th level Spirit Warrior monster core, four 3rd level, four 4th level, and eight 1st level Spirit Warrior monster cores.

'18 monster cores, huh. I wonder if this will be enough for me to breakthrough to the Spirit Master realm...' Yuan thought to himself.

He needed approximately 12 billion Qi Experience in order to breakthrough to Spirit Master, but he wasn't sure if these monster cores would be enough.

"Young Master, what do you plan on doing with so many monster cores? If you're trying to reach the Spirit Master realm, I don't think you'll be able to with that little amount of monster cores, and it'll take you months to absorb them." Feng Yuxiang said to him, completely unaware of Yuan's heaven-defying physique.

"You think so too, Feng Feng? If only I had a Spirit Master monster core," he sighed.

"I have a Spirit Grandmaster monster core, but that's too much for you to handle, Young Master. Furthermore, it's not an ordinary monster core, so it'll be even more difficult to absorb. If you're not careful with it, the monster core could even attack you as you absorb it, destroying your cultivation base."

"Destroy my cultivation...?" Yuan could feel his back beginning to sweat after hearing Feng Yuxiang's words. He should be more careful with consuming monster cores in the future.

"What about these, Feng Feng? Will these monster cores give me any issues?" Yuan asked her a moment later.

"Hmm... I don't think they will..." Feng Yuxiang said after examining the monster cores with her spiritual sense.

"Okay, then I will absorb them," Yuan said in a casual manner.

"Wait a second, Young Master. You're going to absorb them now? Even if you are at the peak of the Spirit Warrior realm, it'll take you at least a week to absorb the eighth level Spirit Warrior monster core, and it won't even be worth the time since you'll only get a very small fraction of its spiritual energy." Feng Yuxiang said to him.

After all, most people absorb monster cores that are above their own level.

"It's okay, Feng Feng. It won't take me a week, and even if it doesn't help me breakthrough, it'll definitely bring me closer to Spirit Master."

After saying those words, Yuan picked up the low-level monster cores first and began tossing them into his mouth one by one like candies.

[Heaven Refining Physique activated]

[38,654,154 Qi has been refined from the Ruby Cavern Toad's monster core]

[31,544,851 Qi has been refined from the Dark Deer's monster core]

[32,441,778 Qi has been refined...]

[70,828,182 Qi has been refined...]

[155,991,394 Qi has been refined...]

When Feng Yuxiang saw this, she nearly lost her mind from shock, and she quickly left his body and appeared in the room.

"W-What are you doing, Young Master?! You can't eat monster cores! Hurry and spit it out!" Feng Yuxiang spoke in a panicked voice, even sticking her fingers into Yuan's mouth to try and search for the monster cores, almost like a mother trying to dig out something her baby wasn't supposed to put into their mouth, but alas, the monster cores had already melted the moment it touched his tongue.

"Calm down, phoenix..."

Xiao Hua also came out of her necklace and pulled Feng Yuxiang away from Yuan.

"B-But the Young Master swallowed some monster cores! The last time someone did that, he exploded into a bloody mess!" Feng Yuxiang said, as she could still remember that one time thousands of years ago when she'd witnessed someone swallowing monster cores and the consequences of such actions.

"Brother Yuan is okay... He has a special physique that allows him to consume monster cores without any problems... See? He's still fine." Xiao Hua pointed to Yuan, who was startled by Feng Yuxiang's exaggerated reaction.

"R-Really?" Feng Yuxiang wiped the tears that had gathered in the corner of her eyes after realizing that Yuan hadn't exploded into a bloody mess yet.

"Yes... I am perfectly fine." Yuan confirmed.

Feng Yuxiang released a long and deep sigh afterward, feeling like she'd just lost a few hundred years of her lifespan from shock just now.

Xiao Hua merely shook her head, as she knew very well what Feng Yuxiang felt since she had experienced the same shocking experience firsthand.

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Chapter 228 - Above Divine

"A-Are you sure there are no side-effects to eating monster cores, Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang asked him a moment later, as she was still not convinced that one could consume monster cores like that.

"Look, I'll even eat another one to prove to you that nothing happens," Yuan said to her as he popped another monster core into his mouth and swallowed it.

[Heaven Refining Physique activated]

[134,655,197 Qi has been refined from the Assassin Leopard's monster core]

Feng Yuxiang experienced another minor heart attack after seeing Yuan eat another monster core.

"Brother Yuan has been doing this way before he met you and nothing bad has happened to him yet so we can assume that it's safe," Xiao Hua said a moment later.

After a moment of silence, Feng Yuxiang spoke in a dazed voice, "Young Master, if you don't mind, can you tell me what kind of physique you have that allows you to consume monster cores like that? I have never heard of such a heaven-defying physique even in the upper heavens."

Yuan nodded and said, "Heaven Refining Physique."

"Heaven Refining Physique?" Feng Yuxiang raised her slender eyebrows in a manner as she has never heard of such a thing before.

Then she closed her eyes to ponder.

After many moments of silence, she suddenly snapped her eyes open and shouted in a voice of realization, "That's right! I have heard of this physique before!"

"Eh? Really?" Both Yuan and Xiao Hua looked at her with anticipation in their gazes.

Feng Yuxiang nodded and said, "If I remember correctly, I heard about the Heaven Refining Physique once before over 50,000 years ago when I was still roaming the upper heavens. It's a legendary physique that has existed only once before, and the individual who had that physique was said to be an incredible cultivator who dominated the heavens. Unfortunately, that's all I know."

"I see... So someone else had this physique before..." Yuan mumbled.

"Well, that's only natural," said Feng Yuxiang, and she continued, "In this world, there can be multiple people with the same physique. Of course, the rarer and stronger the physique, the fewer people will have them. However, there are some really special physiques in this world that can exist only in one person at a time as mandated by the heavens, as they are simply too powerful to exist in multiple people. In other words, unless that person dies, nobody else can be born with the physique."

"In your case, Young Master, the person who used to have the same physique was a legend from countless years ago in the ancient times, so we can assume that he's long passed away, as only real immortals at the peak of cultivation can exist for that long, or else he wouldn't be a mere legend."

And she continued, "Does your physique do anything else besides allow you to consume monster cores?"

Yuan shook his head and said, "Not that I know of. Can physiques have multiple powers?"

Feng Yuxiang nodded and said, "Of course. The more powerful the physique the more likely it'll have a second, even a third effect."

"What about the rank? Do you know the rank of your physique, Young Master?"

Yuan nodded and said, "Celestial."

"Celestial? What rank is that?" Feng Yuxiang raised her eyebrows in a truly puzzled manner, as this is her first time hearing of such a rank.

"Above the Divine-rank is the Ancient-rank, and above Ancient-rank is Mythic-rank, so I can only assume that the Celestial-rank is above the Mythic-rank, which is quite hard to believe if I am being honest..." Feng Yuxiang mumbled in a low voice.

"After all, you won't see anyone above the Divine-rank in the Lower Heavens, much less the Celestial-rank that is likely above the Ancient and Mythic-rank. It just doesn't sound plausible unless the Young Master was born in the upper heavens."

"That's not possible," Yuan shook his head. Forget about the upper heavens, he wasn't even born in the Lower Heavens.

The only logical reason for this is that Players such as himself don't abide by the laws of this world, hence why they're able to cultivate much quicker and defy the laws in this world. After all, if one thinks about it, Players are Otherworlders who came from another world— Earth. It shouldn't be too far-fetched to think that they would have an advantage over the people of this world since they're Players comparing themselves to NPCs.

"Anyway, I am going to consume the rest of these monster cores. Hopefully, they'll help me reach Spirit Master."

Yuan proceeded to toss the rest of the monster cores into his mouth, and Feng Yuxiang could only watch this unfathomable scene with a dazed look on her face.

[Heaven Refining Physique activated]

[1,841,243,648 Qi has been refined from the Preying Howler's monster core]

[40,594,785 Qi has been refined from the Bladed Jackal's monster core]

[69,347,481 Qi has been refined from the Greater Storm Wolf's monster core]

[5,652,214,875 Qi has been refined from the Lonely Giant Screamer's monster core]

"E-Even the eighth level Spirit Warrior monster core was swallowed without any problems... Just how powerful of a heaven-defying physique is this Heaven Refining Physique?" Feng Yuxiang mumbled in a low voice, feeling a chill in her spine after watching Yuan's shocking performance.

'Hmmm... I'd only managed to absorb a little over 9 billion Qi from all of the monster cores. I still need three more billion Qi Experiences before I can breakthrough to Spirit Master...' Yuan thought to himself afterward. Where else can he obtain these 3 billion Qi Experiences? Cultivating normally would take too long, and the Treasury Hall already gave him all of their monster cores.

"Hopefully, the Dragon Peak will be able to help me obtain the last three billion Qi and allow me to breakthrough to Spirit Master..." Yuan mumbled as he gazed outside the window.

Sometime later, once they calmed down, Xiao Hua and Feng Yuxiang returned inside Yuan's body. And since there was nothing else to do until the Inner Court disciple examination next week, Yuan decided to log off for the day to cultivate in the real world.

Chapter 229 - Parents

After cultivating in the real world for a couple of hours, Yuan stopped his cultivation and waited for Yu Rou to enter his room.

Suddenly, he could hear footsteps approaching his room. However, these graceful and quiet steps did not belong to Yu Rou.

A few moments later, the door opened, and Meixiu's voice resounded, "Good evening, Young Master. I will be attending you tonight because the Young Lady has been summoned by the Masters."

"Our parents? Do you know why?" Yuan asked her.

"I do not, Young Master."

"I understand. Thank you."

A few moments later, Meixiu began removing Yuan's clothes and wiping him down with a wet towel.

"Young Master, if you don't mind me asking, you'd participated in a musical competition in Cultivation Online, right? I heard about it from the Young Lady." Meixiu suddenly asked him.

"Yes, I did."

"What kind of instrument did you play?" she then asked.

"An instrument called the zither," Yuan casually said.

"Did you win? Knowing the Young Master, you most likely placed first again."

"I did."

"C-Congratulations, Young Master," Meixiu said in a somewhat surprised voice.

After wiping his body, Meixiu began feeding Yuan his three bowls of soup.

'Could the Young Master be Player Yuan who's currently dominating the game and causing a commotion around the world with his mysterious identity? Although it's hard to believe, their stories line up...' Meixiu thought to herself. While she doesn't particularly care about matters outside of the Yu Family, the countless talks about Player Yuan have also caught her interest recently.

Meanwhile, in a separate household a couple of miles away from Yuan's home, Yu Rou stood before two individuals— a handsome middle-aged man and a beautiful middle-aged woman.

"Yu Rou, do you know why we called you here today?" The middle-aged man asked her.

"I do not, father." Yu Rou responded in a calm voice.

Indeed, these two individuals were the sibling's parents, Yu Yong, the father, and Tang Lee, the mother.

After a moment of silence, Yu Yong spoke, "Do you know of the game 'Cultivation Online'?"

"Eh?"

Yu Rou's eyes widened at Yu Yong's unexpected question, as she never expected things that were not related to music would come out of their parent's mouth.

"I-I have... I even played it for a couple of days during my vacation," she responded after her initial surprise.

Tang Lee then said, "Well, the other families have been talking about it recently, or more specifically, they have been talking about an individual who goes by the name of 'Player Yuan'. Do you know of this person?"

"I do... He's all over the internet, after all." Yu Rou nodded in a somewhat dazed manner, silently wondering to herself why their parents were suddenly interested in Player Yuan who was their own son.

Yu Yong then said, "The children from the other families have recently participated in this musical competition related to the 'zither' within Cultivation Online, and they told their families that this Player Yuan was without a doubt a musical genius with strong beliefs that he belongs to a family with a music background."

And he continued, "I have heard of this Player Yuan before but never really paid attention to him, but if he's really a musical genius, I would like to meet him."

"Why do you want to meet him, father? He's just a gamer who's decent with the zither, right? Even if he's a genius with the zither, there's no guarantee that he could play the other instruments as well. Furthermore, nobody plays the zither anymore." Yu Rou asked him.

"It doesn't matter how many instruments he can play. Our company is always looking for talented people, and if this Player Yuan is as talented as they say, I want him to play for my company!" Yu Yong said.

Yu Rou shook her head and said, "I'm afraid that's impossible for now, father. Everybody has been looking for Player Yuan's real identity since the game started weeks ago, but nobody has been able to learn anything to date."

"I know—I have been researching about him as well. However, I don't believe that he'll be able to hide his identity forever. Sooner or later, his identity will be revealed, and when that happens, I will be the first one to greet him." Yu Yong said with a serious look on his face.

"Anyways, the reason I called you here today is to let you know that we will begin doing our tours in Cultivation Online instead of the real world, as that seems to be the trend nowadays."

"W-What? How does that work?" Yu Rou stared at them with a gawking look on her face.

"Simple. We will start doing concerts in the game to spread our company's reputation within the game. The other families have already been doing this and to great success. Therefore, we shall be doing the same as well."

"Y-You don't mean..." Yu Rou swallowed nervously after hearing this, as she could feel an ominous feeling looming in the atmosphere.

"I've heard from others that even people who cannot see or move in the real world can operate like they're perfectly healthy inside the game. If that's the case, then we can have Yu Tian play the game and start playing instruments again within the game. He has been useless for far too long, and it's about time he steps onto the stage again, albeit a virtual one."

Yu Rou silently gritted her teeth when she heard this, yet she didn't know what she could say at this moment.

"What... What if Brother Tian doesn't want to do it?" Yu Rou asked a moment later.

Tang Lee then spoke in a cold voice, "He doesn't have a choice in this. If he doesn't want to do it, then we will simply disown him and kick him out of the house, as we have no use for someone who does nothing but eat up our money and resources. It's not cheap maintaining someone in his condition even for us, after all."

Chapter 230 - Yu Tians Decision

Chapter 230 - Yu Tian's Decision

"T-That's unreasonable, mother! Where will Brother Tian go if you kick him out?! He cannot do anything by himself, either! You cannot do this to him!" Yu Rou immediately said.

"How dare you raise your voice at me, Yu Rou!" Tang Lee shouted back, and then she continued, "We have spent hundreds of millions of dollars in these last 10 years on that boy's medical bill hoping that he can be healed! However, it's very clear to us that his condition is permanent! If that's the case, why should we continue to waste our money on someone like him?! There are things in life you must give up, even if that 'thing' is family!"

"But Brother Tian has brought fame and reputation to our family and company! How can you throw him away like trash after everything he's done for the family?! He'd even sacrificed his childhood so that our family could prosper!" Yu Rou did not care about getting scolded and continued to defend Yu Tian, as she cannot imagine a life without him.

"It is true that his talents have brought our family and company to the peak of the musical world—that we won't deny. However, we've paid him back and more with the millions we've spent on him for the last 10 years. If he doesn't want to continue contributing to the family, then there's no reason for him to remain in this family. We've thought long and hard about this, and this is our decision. If you don't want that, then it'd be in your best interest to convince Yu Tian to comply with our request and play for the family again." Yu Yong said to her with a stern expression on his face.

"...I understand." Yu Rou said after a moment of silence.

Sometime later, Yu Rou left her parent's living quarters and returned to her own place.

On her way home, she pondered how she should relay this news to Yu Tian and convince him to play for the family again.

Once she'd returned, Yu Rou went straight to Yuan's room. However, she didn't immediately enter his room and stood outside in front of the doors for many minutes.

"What's wrong, Yu Rou?" Yuan's voice resounded from inside the room.

Yu Rou took a deep breath before entering the room, and she said in a solemn voice, "I spoke with father and mother today."

"I know. Meixiu told me." Yuan said.

"What did you talk about this time? Did your grades lower again?" Yuan spoke in a joking voice.

However, Yu Rou didn't smile, nor did she respond to his question.

"What's the matter, Yu Rou?" Yuan asked her, feeling something amiss from the quiet atmosphere.

"Well... You might not like what I am about to tell you, but this is something I must tell you," Yu Rou said, and she began telling him about what had occurred at her meeting with their parents as well as the conversation.

"Because the other families have been bringing their music into Cultivation Online, mother and father decided to do the same, and they want you to start playing the instruments again." Yu Rou said to him, leaving out the part about disowning him if he refuses for now.

"..."

Yuan immediately became speechless after listening to Yu Rou's words, and after a long moment of silence, he spoke, "So... They want me to repeat what I did when I was young in Cultivation Online?"

"Yes, they want you to start playing the game but purely focusing on music."

After another moment of silence, Yuan said in a sighing voice, "If I hadn't experienced the beautiful world that is Cultivation Online, I would've probably agreed. However, I have many things to do inside the game, so I won't have time to do what they want me to. Even if I do have time, I refuse to play the instrument for them."

Yu Rou began sweating when she heard Yuan's decision, and she began trying to convince him, "Why don't you think about it again, brother? You'll be able to return to your previous spotlight, and people will finally stop looking down on you. I also want to hear you play music again."

However, Yuan remained reluctant and said, "There's no need for me to think about it. I want to explore the cultivation world of my own free will. If you want to listen to my music, just let me know and I'll play for you, Yu Rou."

"..."

It was Yu Rou's turn to remain silent this time, and after a long moment of silence, she spoke in almost a crying voice, "Brother... I didn't want to tell you this at first because I know it'll hurt you, but... Mother and father said that if you don't comply, they'll disown you and kick you out of the house..."

"Oh... Is that so..."

Even though Yuan's voice remained somewhat calm, he could feel a painful sensation in his heart for a few seconds after learning that he might be disowned. After all, anybody would feel betrayed if their parents said they'd disown them non-jokingly.

Sometime later, Yuan said in a calm yet somewhat cold voice, "If they are going to disown me purely because I don't want to work as a puppet for them again, then they can disown me. I don't want to spend the rest of my

life as a puppet. Instead, I want to live the rest of my life to the fullest so I don't have any regrets when I inevitably pass."

"B-But where are you going to go, brother?! Think about this for a second! You won't be able to survive by yourself! And don't make it sound like you're going to die anytime soon because you're not! Even Doctor Wang said that you're growing healthier!"

"It'll be okay, Yu Rou. I will figure something out, and this is a good opportunity to finally set you free from your responsibilities and live a normal life."

"No! I don't want that! I want to continue taking care of you forever!" Yu Rou quickly refused.

"You know you can't do that, Yu Rou. After all, you also have your own life to live." Yuan sighed, wondering what he can say to convince his little sister to give up on him so that she could also live her life to its fullest.

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Chapter 231 - Planning To Leave The Family

"Yu Rou, how about we end this conversation here today? I would like to think about it some more... alone." Yuan suddenly suggested.

After a moment of silence, Yu Rou said, "Okay... I'll leave you alone for tonight. Please think about this carefully, brother. I don't want to be separated from you."

"Un."

After turning off the lights, Yu Rou left Yuan's room and returned to her own room.

However, just as she prepared to sleep, her phone began ringing.

Yu Rou looked at the caller; it was from her father, Yu Yong.

"Yes, father?"

"Did you speak to him?" Yu Yong asked her.

"I did, father."

"What was his response?"

"Brother Tian... He said that he needed some more time to think about it." Yu Rou said.

"Hmph!"

A cold snort immediately followed, and Yu Yong said, "What does he even need to think about? The answer should already be obvious! Did the illness start affecting his brain?! Yu Rou! You tell him that he has three days to decide! If he doesn't decide by then, we'll decide for him by disowning him!"

"I... I understand, father. I'll tell Brother Tian."

Yu Rou tossed her phone on the bed after Yu Yong ended the call.

Plop!

Yu Rou's body suddenly collapsed onto the bed in an exhausted manner.

"How did it come to this...? I just wanted to live a peaceful life with Brother Tian even if I had to take care of him forever..." she sighed.

Meanwhile, inside his own room, Yuan tossed his plan to cultivate for the night and began pondering what he should do now that he's been thrown into this difficult situation so suddenly.

As much as he wanted to remain inside the family and stay with Yu Rou, he didn't want to continue playing the instruments just so his family, mostly his parents, could feed off his fame and hard work. Furthermore, if his family disowns him, he will finally have a good excuse to tell Yu Rou to stop taking care of him so she could also live a normal life.

'The cultivation world... I want to explore more of it— every nook and cranny if possible. But that won't be possible if I spend most if not all of my time playing the instruments like I used to. But... How am I supposed to live alone when my body is like this? Like Yu Rou had said, I cannot survive by myself...'

'Even if I can somehow manage by myself, where can I go?'

'Wait... I should have a bank account with a couple of thousands inside. Maybe I can use that money to move out and then find some way to earn more money.'

'But how can I earn money when I'm in this condition? If only I can earn money just by playing Cultivation Online...'

Yuan proceeded to spend the entire night thinking about his plan just in case his family really decided to disown him.

The following morning, Yu Rou came to his room, and she asked him in a tired voice, almost like she didn't get any sleep, "Brother... Did you think about it? Father... He said you only have three days to decide or he'll disown you."

"I don't need three days to decide, since I have already come to a decision." Yuan said, and he continued, "I know you want me to stay here, but I really don't want to give up my freedom even in Cultivation Online as I had in the past. I know you don't want this, but I also want you to live your life without any large responsibilities like taking care of me every day, and it's not like we're not going to see each other ever again."

"But where are you going to go? Who will take care of you? How are you going to survive?" Yu Rou asked him.

"You're probably going to laugh at me for saying this after what I just said, but I'll need your help for a few more things if I want to live by myself. Can you do that for me? If not... I'll just let fate decide my life." Yuan said in a sighing voice.

"..."

After a moment of silence, Yu Rou sighed, "What do you need me to do for you, brother? I'll hear you out at least. What's your plan?"

"I should have an account with a few thousand dollars inside, and I'll use that money to move to another place, which should last me a couple of months. I'll also use some of that money to hire someone who can take care of me in your place. This way, you won't have to worry about me as much anymore. However, I'll need someone you can trust to take care of me."

"I also plan on making money, but I'm not sure how I can do that at the moment. Perhaps there is a way I can earn real-life money by playing Cultivation Online."

"Hmm..." Yu Rou listened to Yuan's plans with a serious look on her face.

"I understand your plans..." Yu Rou spoke after pondering for a moment, and she continued, "I guess you can use that money to move out of the house and hire a maid or something, but who will fit that role? I don't think there is anyone that I trust enough to take care of you every day. As for making money through Cultivation Online, that is very possible, as you can sell items or gold in the game for real-life currency. In fact, it's already a huge market with tens of millions of dollars being traded every day."

"Really? I can do that? If that's the case, I can simply sell some things and earn money that way," Yuan said.

"But you'll need someone to do that for you since you obviously can't do it yourself, and that might give away your identity, so it's really risky unless the person doing it can be trusted." Yu Rou sighed.

Chapter 232 - I Can Only Trust You

"Well, can you think of someone? I can only think of one person when it comes to 'trust'." Yuan said a moment later.

"Really? Who?" Yu Rou asked in a truly puzzled voice.

"Meixiu," Yuan quickly answered.

"..."

Yu Rou turned silent.

"It's true that Meixiu can be trusted... But..." Yu Rou pondered with a perplexed frown on her face.

While she can trust Meixiu to take care of Yuan in her stead, even keeping his secret as Player Yuan, she was worried that they would develop some sort of relationship with each other from spending too much time together and that her relationship with Yuan might grow further apart as a result.

"Oh, right... She's your personal maid, nor can we really separate her from you just to help me, much less giving her such a burden that is me... That would be way too selfish of me. I guess we'll just have to find some random person to help me and hope for the best. If my identity as Player Yuan is revealed, it is what it is... I highly doubt that'll make my life more miserable than currently," Yuan sighed.

"..."

Yu Rou turned silent once again, and then she said a moment later, "Brother... Let me speak with Meixiu to see if she wants to help you. Of course, I won't command her or anything like that, and it will be entirely up to her whether she helps or not. How does that sound?"

"Are you sure? You've been with Meixiu for all your life, and she has been your servant for as long as well. I don't think I can really separate the two of you."

"Don't worry, brother. It's not like Meixiu will stop helping me. Furthermore, I can say the same to you, as Meixiu has been in our lives for almost the same time, and she's almost like a second sister to us at this point."

"I guess you can go ahead and ask her. However, don't force her, Yu Rou. Even if you are trying to help me, I don't want you to force Meixiu, because I won't accept her help if that's the case."

"Who do you think I am, brother? I am not unreasonable like some people in this family. I won't force her—I swear."

"Okay... If you say so."

"Are you going to play Cultivation Online today?" Yu Rou asked him after their daily routine.

"No, I'll take a break today. There's nothing to do until next week, anyway."

"Okay."

After cleaning up, Yu Rou went to eat her own breakfast and prepared for school.

On her way to school, Yu Rou asked Meixiu while they sat in the car.

"Meixiu, I have something important to ask you." Yu Rou stared at Meixiu in the eyes with a serious look on her face.

"What is it, Young Lady?"

Yu Rou took a deep breath, and she began explaining to her the situation regarding Yuan.

"Well, my parents are thinking about making Brother Tian play instruments inside Cultivation Online as he used to when he was young, but my brother refused. The thing is... if he refuses, they will disown him and kick him out of the house..."

"What?!" Meixiu covered her mouth in shock, as she could almost not believe her ears. "How could the Masters..."

"What does the Young Lady and Young Master plan on doing?" Meixiu couldn't help but ask, as this will definitely change the entire household as a whole.

"We don't really know yet, but Brother Tian intends on leaving the family and living by himself. However, his condition doesn't exactly allow that... Therefore, he's thinking about hiring someone else to take care of him, as he doesn't want me to bear the burden anymore."

"That's very like the Young Master." Meixiu nodded.

"But the problem is that I don't know anyone I trust enough to take care of Brother Tian. There are many bad people out there— heartless people who will mistreat or take advantage of Brother Tian's condition, and I fear that very much." Yu Rou spoke from the bottom of her heart.

While it sounded like she was trying to get sympathy from Meixiu so that she could pressure Meixiu with guilt, that was not the case, as Yu Rou truly feared that someone might take advantage of Yuan.

"Indeed, this world is filled with nasty people." Unexpectedly, Meixiu agreed.

"Anyways, I have been thinking about people who I trust enough to take care of Brother Tian, and after thinking about it for very long, I could only

think of a single person that I trust enough— and that's you, Meixiu."

"M-Me...?" Meixiu pointed at herself with a startled look on her face. "But I am the Young Lady's..."

"I know." Yu Rou quickly interrupted, and she continued, "I know that you're my personal maid and that you've been for almost my entire life, but I can only trust you to take care of Brother Tian. Of course, I am only asking you, and if you refuse, I won't hold anything against you since I know very well from experience how difficult it could be at times to take care of Brother Tian, especially if you're doing it every day for years, and even brother himself said that it's all up to you whether you want to listen to our request or not."

"You don't need to give me an answer right away. Think about it. We'll continue this conversation when we come back home," Yu Rou then said.

"I understand, Young Lady." Meixiu nodded, feeling many perplexed emotions in her heart.

While Yu Rou went to school, Yuan focused on cultivation.

'Now that even my own parents have given up hope on me, I can only rely on Yu Rou and myself to survive! I should've expected this outcome sooner or later!' Yuan gritted his teeth in frustration, his heart burning with the desire and passion to crawl out of this hellhole.

'Cultivation is now my only hope to recover! Even if it's not a full recovery, I will be satisfied with a partial recovery!'

At this moment, unbeknownst to Yuan, the flames within his heart began pulsating, and the golden symbols engraved in his bones began to glow brightly.

Chapter 233 - Meixius Decision

Chapter 233 - Meixiu's Decision

Although Yuan was unaware of the subtle changes within his body, the golden symbols engraved in his bones glowed brightly and emitted this profound aura that attracted the nearby spiritual energy, vastly increasing Yuan's spiritual energy absorption rate.

Meanwhile, the mysterious flame inside his heart pulsed as though it had become a heart itself, and with each beat, the spiritual energy he'd absorbed was instantly purified and enhanced, greatly boosting its effectiveness.

With these two profound and mysterious powers inside his body, Yuan's cultivation speed soared to a level that rivaled even his cultivation speed in Cultivation Online without eating monster cores.

'What's going on? Why did my cultivation speed suddenly increase so much?'

Even without knowledge of what's happening inside his body, Yuan could tell that something had changed, as his cultivation speed had suddenly increased.

However, he wasn't complaining. And worried that it was only temporary, Yuan focused on cultivating without thinking about anything else.

Whoosh!

A fresh feeling suddenly exploded within his body, signaling that he had a breakthrough, reaching 8th level Spirit Apprentice in just one hour since he began cultivating.

The same refreshing feeling occurred again just three hours later, meaning Yuan had another breakthrough, reaching the peak Spirit Apprentice.

'I had managed to enter Spirit Warrior previously without needing any enlightenment, but that is most likely because of the game. If I want to achieve the same feat in the real world, I'll probably have to experience this enlightenment. Let's see if I can make another breakthrough again.'

With that in mind, Yuan began cultivating again.

Six hours later, Yuan could feel his body filled to the brim with spiritual energy, yet he could not enter Spirit Warrior, almost like there was something preventing him from advancing.

'So this is what Xiao Hua meant by needing enlightenment to continue. However, how does one achieve enlightenment?' Yuan began pondering.

But alas, no matter how much he thought about it, he had zero clues about enlightenment.

'I should ask Xiao Hua about it tomorrow...'

Meanwhile, after school, Yu Rou got into her limousine with Meixiu.

Once the door closed and the car began moving, they resumed their conversation from this morning.

"Have you thought about it, Meixiu?" Yu Rou asked her.

Meixiu nodded, and then she spoke, "Young Lady, if you don't mind me asking, what will happen to us if I decide to help the Young Master? Will I still be serving you?"

"I want you to focus on taking care of my brother, and I don't want to overwork you, so I'll find someone else to take care of my needs. Don't worry, it's not like you're fired. You're just being hired by my brother instead." Yu Rou said.

"I'll even pay you for him. This way, Brother Tian will have less burden."

"I don't really care for the money, Young Lady. If money is my only reason to work for you, I would've left long ago since I have already saved up

enough money to quit my job." Meixiu said.

And she continued, "I know how much the Young Master means to you, and I am also indebted to the Young Master for many things in the past, so if the both of you need my help, I'll do my best."

"D-Does this mean you're willing to take care of Brother Tian?" Yu Rou asked her for confirmation.

Meixiu nodded with a slight smile on her face, and she said, "Only if the Young Lady allows me to continue working for her even if I am already taking care of the Young Master. Of course, I will still prioritize the Young Master, but if I have some free time, I would like to work for you then."

"Meixiu... I don't even know how I should thank you..." Yu Rou could feel herself tearing up.

"You don't have to thank me for anything, Young Lady. I am merely doing my job."

Yu Rou nodded, "Then it's decided. We'll talk more about this once we return to my brother."

Sometime later, the limousine stopped in front of their home, and Yu Rou and Meixiu headed directly for Yuan's room.

"Brother! I have great news!" Yu Rou said as she opened the door.

"I can hear you perfectly, Yu Rou. There's no need to scream." Yuan said with a smile on his face.

"Meixiu, go ahead and tell him!" Yu Rou said to Meixiu who'd just entered the room.

Meixiu then approached the bed before bending her body and bowing to Yuan.

"Young Master, I, Meixiu, will be in your care starting today."

"Huh? Does this mean you're willing to leave Yu Rou's side to come work for me? If that's the case, I should be the one saying that..." Yuan said in a somewhat dazed voice.

"Yes, but I won't be leaving the Young Lady's side. I have decided to work for the both of you, as I'd been trained for this very purpose." Meixiu said.

"Isn't this great, brother? Now that we have taken care of your caretaker problem, we only have two more problems left! Your new home and..."

Yu Rou suddenly stopped in the middle of her sentence. She then went to close the door and continued in a lower voice, "Meixiu, we're about to tell you a very big secret that you must not reveal to anybody— not even my parents, okay?!"

"Not even the Masters?" Meixiu swallowed nervously. What kind of secret are they going to tell her?

"Can you promise to not tell another soul, Meixiu? This secret is very related to taking care of Brother Tian as well."

Meixiu nodded with a serious look and said, "I promise, Young Lady, that I won't tell another soul even if I'm tortured to death."

"T-That's a little bit extreme but okay..." Yu Rou was taken aback by Meixiu's seriousness.

"Anyway, do you know about Player Yuan? The player that everybody has been talking about recently? Well, that's—"

Before Yu Rou could even finish her sentence, Meixiu interrupted and said, "Player Yuan is the Young Master, right? I know."

"Eh?" Yu Rou stared at her with a shocked face.

Chapter 234 - A Small Change

"Wait a second... You knew? How did you know that I was Player Yuan? And how long have you known about it?" Yuan asked Meixiu after a moment of silence since Yu Rou was too shocked to speak. "I'm pretty sure we'd kept it hidden pretty well... I think..."

"The musical competition—that's how I learned it," Meixiu said in a calm voice.

"The Young Lady said the Young Master was participating in a music competition, and then Player Yuan managed to obtain first place in a music competition sometime later."

"When I asked the Young Master what kind of instrument he played during his competition, he said it was the zither, which happened to be the same competition Player Yuan had won first place, so I assumed that the Young Master was Player Yuan. It was only after the Young Lady's words just now that confirmed my suspicions."

"So you've only known about it for a day or so?" Yuan asked her.

"That's correct."

"Y-You didn't tell anybody else about this, did you?" Yu Rou finally asked her.

"Of course not, Young Lady. It was only a suspicion until just now, anyway." Meixiu shook her head.

"Well... Since you already know, this will make things much easier for us. Brother Tian will need to earn money in the future, and he intends on selling some things in Cultivation Online for real money. However, it's

obvious that he won't be able to do that by himself, so you'll do that for him, hence why not just anyone can do this job."

Meixiu nodded, "I understand."

"By the way, Brother Tian, while you've already decided to leave the family, let's wait until the last day so we have more time to prepare. Although we've found someone to take care of you, we still need to look for a new home for you. It's the weekend tomorrow, so I'll call some people and see if they have a place. After all, I'd rather you stay with someone I know."

"Okay," Yuan said.

Yu Rou and Meixiu left the room to prepare dinner for Yuan.

An hour later, Yu Rou returned to the room to take care of his needs.

"Yu Rou, I want to play tonight. I've slept enough this morning."

"Okay." Yu Rou said as she fixed his long hair and placed the console on his head before turning the power on.

While Yuan entered the game, Yu Rou cleaned the place and left his room.

Meanwhile, Yuan summoned Xiao Hua.

"Xiao Hua, I have a question regarding something you'd said before. When a cultivator reaches peak Spirit Apprentice, they must experience 'enlightenment' before they can breakthrough to Spirit Warrior, correct?"

"That's right." Xiao Hua nodded.

"What exactly is this enlightenment? Are there any tricks to it?"

"Why do you want to know, Brother Yuan? You're already a Spirit Warrior and even about to become a Spirit Master." Xiao Hua asked him.

"Well... I am just curious about it since I never got to experience it for myself. Furthermore, it might help me if I need to experience enlightenment for Spirit Master."

Xiao Hua nodded and then said, "Close your eyes, Brother Yuan."

Yuan didn't question her and closed his eyes.

Once Yuan closed his eyes, Xiao Hua lifted her small hands and poked Yuan between his eyebrows with her finger.

A small light appeared between Yuan's forehead for a split second before disappearing.

Meanwhile, inside Yuan's head, he was experiencing enlightenment. However, it was not his own enlightenment. Instead, it was Xiao Hua's enlightenment when she first broke through to Spirit Warrior, and she was merely sharing her experience with him through a mysterious technique.

"So this is what enlightenment feels like, huh?" Yuan mumbled, and he opened his eyes a few seconds later.

Although it felt much longer inside his head, it only lasted a few seconds in reality.

"There are really no tricks to receiving enlightenment, Brother Yuan. However, it might help you if you have felt it before."

"I see... Thanks a bunch, Xiao Hua! I'll see you again tomorrow!"

Yuan immediately logged off and began trying to gain enlightenment for himself while the feeling was still fresh.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan recalled what he'd experienced just now and began cultivating with that in mind.

Yuan quickly entered a tranquil state of mind where he thought of nothing, almost like he was half asleep.

A few hours later, Yuan felt as though the invisible wall that had been blocking him from progressing had suddenly collapsed, allowing his spiritual energy to flow forward, breaking through to Spirit Warrior.

Whoosh~!

A gust of wind appeared in the room despite the closed windows, and the thin blankets covering Yuan's body were sent flying off the bed.

In this dark room with all light sources turned off, a faint golden light could be seen around Yuan's body at this moment, and inside Yuan's body, he could feel a tingly sensation coursing through his veins across his body.

A couple of moments later, the light subdued and the wind disappeared.

'This is what Spirit Warrior feels like in the real world? I feel more energetic and powerful than I did in Cultivation Online when I first entered Spirit Warrior...'

With so much energy in his body, Yuan couldn't help but try to move his limbs, and to his surprise, while he couldn't move his arms or legs, he could feel rigid movements in his fingers and toes!

'I...I can move?!'

Even though he was barely able to move his fingers and toes for a few seconds, Yuan was ecstatic about this small change, as this meant that he still has hopes for recovery!

And to make sure he wasn't imagining things, Yuan spent the next couple of minutes moving his fingers and toes.

'I-It's real! I am not dreaming! I can really move my body!' Yuan cried inwardly.

Once he'd calmed down, Yuan immediately returned to cultivating. If reaching Spirit Warrior helped him recover some control over his own body, what will happen once he reaches Spirit Master and above? Will he be able to move his limbs next? Maybe he'll even be able to walk again!

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Chapter 235 - Looking For A New Home

Even though he'd broken through to Spirit Warrior, Yuan's cultivation speed did not slow down. Instead, it grew even stronger. In fact, he was absorbing the spiritual energy around him so quickly that it created a very subtle wind in the room, almost like there was a fan on low power inside the room.

By the time morning came, Yuan had advanced another level, reaching 2nd level Spirit Warrior.

Meanwhile, after waking up, Yu Rou immediately went to prepare breakfast.

'Eh? Why's the blanket on the floor?' Yu Rou thought to herself when she entered the room and saw the blanket on the floor.

The windows were closed, so it couldn't have been the wind. However, she didn't think much about it and proceeded with her daily routine.

A few hours later, after feeding Yuan and cleaning him up, Yu Rou prepared for her morning practice.

After morning practice was finished, Yu Rou returned to her room. However, instead of surfing the internet or playing Cultivation Online as she'd planned, Yu Rou looked through the contacts on her phone and began calling people she trusted.

And while there were a lot of contacts on her phone, only a couple of them truly mattered to her.

Yu Rou picked one of these trusted contacts and called it.

Ring~

A few rings later, someone picked up the phone.

"Good morning, Young Lady. Do you need me for something? Did something happen to the Young Master?" Doctor Wang's voice resounded through the phone.

"Doctor Wang, how are you doing? Although this is related to Brother Tian, it's not what you are thinking." Yu Rou said, and she continued, "Due to a few unexpected circumstances, Brother Tian... he's looking for a new place to stay, and I was wondering if you have any places that you're willing to rent to him."

"Huh?"

As Yu Rou had expected, Doctor Wang made a puzzled noise behind the phone and turned silent for a moment.

"If you don't mind me asking, why is the Young Master looking for a new place to stay? What's wrong with his current room? Did he release impurities again?" Doctor Wang asked.

"No, it's nothing like that... I wished it was that simple," Yu Rou sighed.

She continued, "Well... Brother Tian might get kicked out of the house, so we have to look for a new place for him to stay, and I'd prefer it if he rents a place from someone we trust."

"W-What? Why would the Young Master be kicked out of the house?" Doctor Wang's flabbergasted voice resounded.

"It's a long story..." Yu Rou sighed, and she proceeded to explain the situation to Doctor Wang, mostly because he'll be affected by it sooner or later. After all, once their parents disown Yuan, they will no longer pay for his medical bills. Even if Doctor Wang is a very generous individual, there's

no way he'd continue treating Yuan without any payments that would cost him millions each year.

"Heavens... I can't believe it... To think they'd disown the Young Master over something like this..." Doctor Wang was truly speechless.

"Don't worry, Doctor Wang... Even if my parents will no longer pay for Brother Tian's treatment, we'll pay for it instead." Yu Rou said.

Since she knew how much wealth Player Yuan has, if Yuan sold even a portion of his in-game gold and treasures, he'll be able to pay for the medical bills and live comfortably for a while.

"Young Lady... We can talk about that once we get there. For now, let's deal with the situation at hand, and that is finding the Young Master a new residence." Doctor Wang said.

And he continued, "While I don't have any free rooms to rent, I have a few guest rooms available in my main home, and if you don't mind, you can move the Young Master there. That way, I can monitor him with more ease. Of course, it'll be free of charge. You don't need to pay me for rent, as your family has donated more than enough to my hospitals."

"Your main home...?"

Yu Rou immediately hesitated. If this is their main home, Doctor Wang's granddaughter should also be there, and she'd rather not let Yuan so close to her without any supervision.

'I'll let Brother Tian live there if it's our last resort...'

With this in mind, Yu Rou said, "Thank you for your offer, but I can't let Brother Yuan invade your family like this, Doctor Wang. I'll see if there are any other options first. If not, I'll contact you again."

"I understand. My doors will be open for the Young Master whenever. I'm sure my granddaughter Wang Xiuying wouldn't mind having the Young Master here as well." Doctor Wang said.

Yu Rou hung up shortly later and exclaimed afterward, "She's exactly the reason why I don't want Brother Tian living there! Who knows what that fox might do to my brother when I'm not around!"

Sometime later, Yu Rou called a few more people but to no avail.

"Looks like there's only one more person to call..."

Yu Rou picked up the phone and tapped on the name 'Xia Jingyi'.

Ring... Ring... Ring...

"Sister Rou! I was just about to call you! Are you going to play Cultivation Online today? I just finished unboxing the console!"

"Oh... Something else came up, so I won't be able to play this weekend." Yu Rou said.

"What happened? You don't sound happy," Xia Jingyi suddenly asked.

After sighing, Yu Rou responded, "I'm looking to rent a place for my brother. I don't want to go into the details, but he needs to find a new home soon."

"Is that so..."

After a moment of silence, Xia Jingyi said, "Well, if you're looking for a place, how about I lend you one of the rooms in an apartment owned by my parents? You don't have to pay me anything either. It's also not too far away from our school, so you can visit him after school."

"Really?!" Yu Rou immediately became ecstatic after hearing this.

"Yes. I'll let my parents know that it's occupied so they don't rent it out by accident." Xia Jingyi said.

"Thank you so much! I'll definitely repay you for this when I get the chance!"

"You don't have to repay me, Sister Rou. After all, we're friends, and you've already done enough for me at school. If anything, I should be the one repaying you for everything you've done for me." Xia Jingyi said with a warm smile on her face.

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Chapter 236 - Moving Out

After talking with Xia Jingyi for a few minutes on the phone, Yu Rou hung up and went to Yuan's room to relay the news to him.

"Brother, I've found a place for you to stay at, and it's even for free!"

"Really? How did you find this place?" Yuan couldn't help but ask.

"Do you remember that time I mentioned my classmate who was a sweet girl? I spoke to her just now, and she said that you can move into her apartment for free!"

"I see... Thank you, Yu Rou, for helping me with this... None of this would've been possible without you." Yuan said.

"Don't even mention it!" Yu Rou chuckled.

"Anyway, when do you plan on moving out?"

"I can move out now if everything is prepared," Yuan said.

"Well, you have someone to take care of you, and you have a place to stay. Now we just need to worry about your medical expenses and whatnot." Yu Rou said.

"It's fine, Yu Rou. I don't think I'll need to do any more checkups. After all, I've been doing it for the past ten years without any different result; it's just a waste of money at this point." Yuan said, not mentioning his slight recovery just yet, as he wanted to be able to move at least his limbs before telling her.

"Are you sure? I still think it would be better if we have Doctor Wang check your body every once in a while." Yu Rou said.

"I guess we can do that."

"Anyway, since there's nothing else, we can move whenever you want, brother."

"Let's move out now. I don't want to stay in this place any longer." Yuan said.

"Okay. Let me get your wheelchair."

Yu Rou went outside and returned a couple of minutes later with the wheelchair.

"Brother, I think we should get you cleaned first before you leave. After all, it might be more difficult to clean you in your new home." Yu Rou suddenly suggested.

"Okay."

Thus, Yu Rou placed Yuan in the wheelchair before pushing him to the bathroom.

Once the bathtub was ready with warm water, Yu Rou rinsed Yuan's body and washed him before carrying him into the bathtub.

"Brother... you've gotten noticeably heavier... I'm already starting to have trouble carrying you." Yu Rou said, and she continued, "Even your body... It's definitely much meatier than last week, and even your muscles are somewhat refined! Is this because of the soup or something else?"

Yu Rou was pleasantly surprised when she realized just how much Yuan's body has changed compared to last week. It would be like comparing a skeleton to a healthy body!

"Who knows, but isn't this a good thing? Maybe I'll even suddenly start walking again next month if it continues like this!" Yuan laughed in a non-

joking voice.

"Don't worry, bother. No matter what, I will not lose hope. Even if our parents give up, I will never give up on you..." Yu Rou said in a somewhat sobbing voice.

If Yuan could turn around and see Yu Rou's face right now, he would see tears dripping from her beautiful face.

"Yu Rou..." Yuan sighed.

'While I cannot do anything for her in this world... if it's Cultivation Online...'

After thinking for a moment, Yuan said, "Yu Rou... You've always wanted me to return to the spotlight, right?"

"Eh?" Hearing Yuan's sudden question, Yu Rou quickly wiped her tears and said, "Of course. Brother's the most handsome when he's surrounded in that dazzling light, and I want people to look at you in admiration like previously."

"I don't know when I'll be able to return to that spotlight in this world, but in Cultivation Online, where I can use my body to its full extent and more, I'll do my best."

"What are you talking about, brother? You're already in the spotlight. People just don't know it's you... yet." Yu Rou laughed slightly.

"I know... that's why I'll reveal my identity—I'll let the world know who Player Yuan is, so they'll know it's me." Yuan suddenly said, shocking Yu Rou.

"What?! If you do that, you'll—!"

"Of course I am not going to reveal it now, but once I'm ready, I'll let the world know. The only reason I've been keeping this identity a secret is so that our peaceful life won't be disturbed. However, now that our peace has

been disturbed, it wouldn't matter if I reveal my identity or not. Perhaps I'll even get some help that way."

"While that is true... That's a very risky move. Who knows what will happen once the world learns of your real identity, especially the Legacy Families. They're the ones you should be the most worried about since you've taken their spotlights."

"I see..." Yuan mumbled.

After submerging themselves in the bathtub for many minutes, Yu Rou carried Yuan out of the bathtub and placed him on the drying table whilst she went to dry herself with a towel.

Once she was fully dressed, Yu Rou helped Yuan put on his clothes before carrying him back to his wheelchair.

Upon leaving the bathroom, Yu Rou went to speak with Meixiu.

"Meixiu, I'll bring Brother Tian to his new living quarters now. Can you pack his things in the meantime? It's mostly just his clothes and the console," Yu Rou said to her.

"I understand." Meixiu nodded.

Once Yu Rou and Yuan left the place, Meixiu immediately began packing Yuan's clothes.

And just like Yu Rou had said, there really wasn't much to pack besides some clothes and pajamas. In fact, the biggest thing she had to pack was the gaming device that took up an entire suitcase by itself.

Meanwhile, Yu Rou entered the limousine with Yuan and made their way to the apartment that was only three miles away from the school she was attending, and she called Xia Jingyi before leaving the house to let her know that they were heading there now.

Chapter 237 - 17F

Half an hour after leaving the house, the limousine stopped in front of a large apartment that had over 20 floors, and Yu Rou pushed Yuan towards the entrance, where a young lady with two large assets was standing.

"Sister Rou!" Xia Jingyi waved at her with a delightful look on her face upon seeing their figures.

"I'm sorry for coming here on such short notice, Jingyi," Yu Rou said with an apologetic smile.

"Don't even mention it. I don't live that far away from here, anyway." Xia Jingyi said.

She then looked at Yuan and said, "Hello, Sister Rou's elder brother. My name is Xia Jingyi, a fellow classmate, it's really nice to finally meet you."

"My name's Yu Tian. Thank you for letting me stay here. When I get the chance, I'll definitely repay you."

"We can talk about that later," Xia Jingyi said, and she continued, "Come, let me show you your room."

There were two entrances they had to pass before reaching the elevators. The first entrance led to a small lobby where the mailboxes are kept, whilst the 2nd entrance led to the receptionists and elevators.

"Your room will be on the 17th floor." Xia Jingyi said as she pressed the button inside the elevator.

The elevator door closed, and they began ascending quickly.

A few moments later, they arrived on the 17th floor.

Ding!

The door opened, and Xia Jingyi walked out, followed by Yu Rou and Yuan.

Xia Jingyi stopped in front of the door at the end of the hall and said, "This is 17F, it's the largest and most luxurious room on this floor."

"A-Are you sure?" Yuan spoke in a hesitant voice, and he continued, "You can just give me one of the ordinary rooms. I don't want to feel like I am taking advantage of your kindness, especially since I am living here for free."

Xia Jingyi chuckled and said, "Sister Rou always mentioned how kind and humble you are. Don't worry, it's just one room. It won't affect us at all."

"Here's the keys and a spare one." Xia Jingyi handed Yu Rou two sets of keys after unlocking the doors.

"Thank you."

"Let me show you around." Xia Jingyi opened the door and went inside the apartment room.

"There is a living room, a kitchen, one bathroom with its bathtub and shower separated, three bedrooms, and a balcony. Also, everything in here is new, so it's not been used before. What do you think?"

After a quick tour around the place, Yu Rou nodded, "If I have to be honest, it's much larger than necessary."

And she continued, "The bedroom is good, and the bathroom is also big enough. I don't have any complaints."

"That's great. Then you can move here whenever you feel like it. The keys are already in your hands."

"Once again, thank you for this, Jingyi," Yu Rou said to her.

After talking for some time, Xia Jingyi, "If you ever need me, just call my number and I'll see what I can do."

"Okay," Yuan said.

"By the way, Sister Rou, before I leave you two alone, I am currently in the Eastern Continent at someplace called Red Pearl City."

Yu Rou nodded and said, "I'll see how far away it is and if I'll be able to get there."

"Okay. I'll go do some quests and cultivate some more in the meantime."

After Xia Jiayi left the place, Yuan said, "I'll let Feng Feng know. She should be able to help you meet her since you're both within the Eastern Continent."

"Sounds great. Anyways, let's put you on your new bed so we can get some feedback. If you don't like it, we can change the mattress."

Yu Rou proceeded to push the wheelchair into the largest bedroom before carrying Yuan onto the bed.

"Well? What do you think?"

"It's a bit softer than what I'm used to, but I think I like this better."

"I'll ask you again in a few days." Yu Rou said.

Ring~ Ring~

"It's Meixiu." Yu Rou said after seeing the caller on her phone.

"Are you on your way here, Meixiu?"

"Yes. I am on my way to the address you gave me."

"Okay, call me again when you're downstairs."

After hanging up, Yu Rou and Yuan began talking more about their plans until Meixiu called again.

Once Meixiu arrived, Yu Rou went downstairs to meet her before coming back up.

"This will be Brother Tian's new home." Yu Rou gave Meixiu a tour around the place.

"This place is very close to school, which will make things far more convenient for the both of us."

Meixiu nodded, and then she asked, "What else needs to be done?"

"Well, there's really nothing else to do... Oh, right!" Yu Rou suddenly recalled.

"We need to find a way for Brother Tian to sell his in-game items for real-life currency. It would be risky if Brother Tian traded the treasures personally so it would be for the best if he handed you the treasures instead."

"In other words, we need you to play Cultivation Online!"

"I-I understand..." Meixiu nodded, feeling like it was a weird thing for her to play video games since she has never really touched them before besides a few occasions when Yu Rou wanted to play with her.

"Hopefully, you are also in the Eastern Continent, or that will make things complicated," Yuan said.

And he continued, "Though, Feng Feng should still be able to pick you up... I'll ask her later."

"Feng Feng...?" Meixiu raised her eyebrows.

"Yes, she's a phoenix who can fly at extreme speeds. She'll probably be able to travel to other continents with ease as well. Anyways, we can figure the rest of this out once you create your character."

"Okay."

Sometime later, Yu Rou began unpacking Yuan's luggage whilst Meixiu went to clean the house that was slightly dusty. Once that was done, Meixiu went outside to buy a console so she could play Cultivation Online later.

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Chapter 238 - Meixius Evaluation

Chapter 238 - Meixiu's Evaluation

Meixiu returned to the apartment half an hour later with the console in her grasp.

"Great! Why don't you start playing now?" Yu Rou said to her.

"You want me to play right now, Young Lady?" Meixiu raised her eyebrows.

Yu Rou nodded. "There's nothing else to do until dinner anyways."

"If that's what you want..."

"Let's go to the other room." Yu Rou and Meixiu went to the room next to Yuan's room a few moments later.

Once Meixiu laid on the bed and placed the helmet on her head, Yu Rou said to her, "You can log off after creating your character and looking at the map to see which continent you're on. You'll be transported to one of the four available continents randomly, so let's pray that you end up in the Eastern Continent. See you in a bit."

After pressing the power button, Meixiu could feel her consciousness leaving her body and moving elsewhere, feeling almost like she was ascending to heaven or something similar.

A few moments later, she found herself inside a white room that had been visited by every other player in the world.

Clank!

The space before her suddenly cracked, and to Meixiu's surprise, a young lady around her age appeared from the crack.

"Hmmm... So you're someone from the 'Missing Piece', huh? I was wondering if you guys were anything special, but looking at you now, you don't seem any different than the mortals in our world." The young lady said in a somewhat disappointed voice after staring at Meixiu for a second.

"Umm..." Meixiu had many questions in her head, but she wasn't able to ask any of them due to the young lady speaking before she could.

"Place your hand on this crystal ball so we can get this over with. I've already lost my interest."

Meixiu decided to not ask any questions and placed her hands on the crystal ball.

A few moments later, her status appeared.

Name: Meixiu

Cultivation: None

Legacy: None

Bloodline: None

Physique: Spirit Severing Physique

Physical Strength: 82

Mental Strength: 220

Soul Strength: 555

Physical Defense: 34

Mental Defense: 150

"Oh?"

The young lady's eyebrows raised in a slightly surprised manner when she saw Meixiu's seemingly high stats.

"Spirit Severing Physique, huh? Not bad— Not bad at all. Since you have a Divine-rank physique, you're qualified to become a servant for me at the very least. Here. Take this. If you ever reach the upper heavens, come find me at the Qu Family and show this to the people there."

The young lady surnamed Qu tossed a jade medallion to her before turning around and walking into the crack.

A few moments after the young lady disappeared from the white room, Meixiu was teleported to Mountain #189, one of the thousands of floating mountains around that place, and despite the gaming being out for many weeks now, there were still tens of thousands of new players every day.

After standing around for a few minutes, an NPC appeared before them in the sky, and he began explaining to them about the cultivation world.

Once the explanation ended, he gave the players the Basic Qi Gathering Technique alongside a talisman that told the players their physique's rank.

[Rank: Divine]

Meixiu stared at the word on her talisman that would make countless players and NPCs alike jealous with a somewhat tranquil look on her face, almost like she didn't really care.

"If you have a Heaven-rank or above physique here, raise your hand." The Cultivator in the sky said.

"..."

However, nobody raised their hands.

The Cultivator sucked his teeth in disappointment after seeing this, and he quickly said afterward, "My time is precious and limited. You can all get out of my face now."

And with a wave of his sleeves, all of the players there were sent flying towards the portals in the back.

Once she was standing again, Meixiu brought up the map.

"Western Continent..." Meixiu sighed before logging off the game like Yu Rou had told her to.

After logging off the game, Meixiu removed the helmet from her head and got off the bed.

"Young Lady, I am done." Meixiu knocked on Yuan's door.

"Already? That was quick." Yu Rou opened the door for her, and she continued, "Well? Did you spawn within the Eastern Continent?"

Meixiu shook her head and said, "Unfortunately, I did not, Young Lady. I am currently within the Western Continent."

"How unlucky..." Yu Rou also sighed.

"It'll be fine. I'll talk to Feng Feng after this and see if there's any way we can bring her to the Eastern Continent." Yuan said.

"Okay."

Sometime later, Yu Rou said, "I'll go prepare for your dinner now— Oh, wait... We don't have any ingredients to cook with since we didn't go shopping yet."

"Let me go order some groceries now..."

Yu Rou opened her phone and began buying groceries on a shopping app, allowing them to receive food and groceries without leaving the house.

An hour later, someone knocked on their door and handed off the groceries to Meixiu.

"I'll cook dinner, Young Lady," Meixiu said.

However, Yu Rou immediately refused and said, "Although this won't be my last time cooking for Brother Tian, I won't be able to cook for him as often, so I want to do it properly like usual. You can just relax, Meixiu. After all, you'll be working hard starting tomorrow."

"If you say so, Young Lady..." Meixiu nodded, and she proceeded to sit on the couch doing nothing but stare at the space in front of her with a dazed look.

"..."

Yu Rou was speechless by this, and she sighed, "If you want, you can help me wash the vegetables, I guess..."

"I shall do that then." Meixiu immediately stood up and went to the sink to wash the vegetables.

"Just how much of a workaholic are you, Meixiu? You're still too young to be acting like this..." Yu Rou shook her head, as she didn't know whether to laugh or cry at Meixiu's desire for work.

Chapter 239 - The Truth

After cooking dinner and feeding Yuan, Yu Rou said, "Even though you'd moved out of the house and everything, there's still about two days before you're officially disowned, so I plan on keeping it a secret until then. Who knows, maybe mother and father will even change their minds about disowning you."

"Okay. However, even if they change their mind, I have already decided to leave the family. After all, if one day I recover from this condition, I don't want them to believe that it was all due to their help. I want to prove to them and myself that I can survive even without them." Yuan said.

"If that's your decision, brother, I won't say anything else. I also believe that you'll one day make a full recovery," said Yu Rou.

"Anyways, it's getting late, so I'll head home tonight. I'll be back tomorrow, though." Yu Rou said.

"Okay. See you tomorrow."

After leaving Yuan's apartment, Yu Rou locked the door with the spare keys and quickly returned home.

Meanwhile, Meixiu stayed behind to take care of Yuan.

"Do you need anything, Young Master?" Meixiu asked him.

"Yes, I actually do... Meixiu, can you stop calling me Young Master? I am no longer part of the Yu Family, and there's no need to be so formal to me. Just call me Yu Tian, or even better, Yuan."

"..."

Meixiu did not immediately respond.

After a moment of silence, she suddenly asked him, "When do you plan on telling the Young Lady the truth?"

"..."

"..."

"..."

"The truth... huh."

A bittersweet smile appeared on Yuan's face, and he said, "I wanted to tell her yesterday— No, I planned on telling her if she refused to let me leave the family, but I guess that's no longer needed. However, that's not to say I intend on keeping that secret forever. Once the time is right, I'll tell her."

"I understand."

"Thank you, Meixiu..." Yuan suddenly said, and he continued, "Thank you... for not telling her even though you work with her pretty much every day."

"It's not a big deal, really. I don't think it would change your relationship that much even if she knew."

"Perhaps... But I don't want to risk it." Yuan sighed.

"But she will find out sooner or later, especially now that you're no longer part of the family." Meixiu said, and she continued, "Who knows, maybe the Masters will reveal everything to her once they officially disown you."

"..."

Yuan turned silent after hearing her words.

And he spoke in a solemn voice, "If that happens, it is what is it."

Meixiu shook her head and sighed, "I really don't understand you sometimes, Young Master— Yuan. How hard would it really be for you to say 'we're not blood-related since I was adopted into the family'?"

"You won't understand it even if I told you, Meixiu. The fear of being ignored once someone realizes that you're not who they think you are." Yuan sighed.

"I don't think the Young Lady is that kind of person. Even if you're not real siblings, she won't abandon you." Meixiu said.

"I know she's not, and she most likely won't abandon me, but I still fear that minuscule possibility, and I can't shake off this feeling no matter how much I try. I... really don't want her to hate me for lying to her all these years."

"I wouldn't consider that lying so neither should you. After all, everyone has a secret or two in their lives. Don't think too much about it." Meixiu shook her head.

"If our parents don't tell her first, I'll tell her the truth once I recover from my condition somewhat," Yuan said.

Meixiu looked at Yuan's still body for a moment before speaking, "Yuan... Do you really believe that you'll be able to recover fully?"

Yuan chuckled at her words and said, "Of course not. However, there's no harm in hoping for the best."

"I see..."

"Anyway, you can go rest. I'll be on Cultivation Online tonight to see if I can bring you to the Eastern Continent." Yuan said.

"I understand. Goodnight."

"Goodnight."

Once Yuan entered the game, Meixiu went to the bathroom to wash herself before going to sleep shortly later.

Inside the game, Yuan called for Feng Yuxiang and asked her, "Feng Feng, do you think you can bring someone from the Western Continent to the Eastern Continent?"

"The Western Continent? I can. But why?"

"I have a friend there, and I have some business with her. How long do you think it'll take to bring her here?"

"It shouldn't take too long— probably a few days, even less if we take the teleportation devices. Do you want me to bring your friend from the Western Continent here, Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang asked.

Yuan nodded, and he said, "Yes, but before that, can you bring my sister, Yu Rou, to a place called Red Pearl City? She's still in Phoenix City, and her permit expired."

Feng Yuxiang nodded, "That won't be a problem. When do you want me to go?"

"You can start making your way there now. I'll tell her to meet you there sometime tomorrow." Yuan said.

"It's fine, I have memorized her aura, so I will be able to find her no matter where she is as long as she's within the city. However, it'll still be better to have a meeting point. How about the Golden Phoenix Bazaar where we first met?"

"Okay. I'll tell her that."

"Then I'll be back after I transport your sister. See you later, Young Master."

"Thank you for your help, Feng Feng."

"Don't even mention it, Young Master. It's my pleasure to assist you."

Feng Yuxiang left the Dragon Essence Temple shortly later and soared towards Phoenix City, shocking the sect elders and disciples within the sect with her fiery appearance.

And shortly after Feng Yuxiang left, someone knocked on the door to Yuan's house.

"Is this where Disciple Yuan lives?! You had an official match today, and you missed it! If you don't show up tomorrow, you'll be punished according to the sect rules!"

"What?" Yuan was shocked when he heard this. Where did this match come from? And who's he fighting?

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Chapter 240 - Official Match

Chapter 240 - Official Match

After hearing the knock on the doors, Yuan went downstairs to see who was knocking on the door.

Upon seeing the middle-aged man standing before him, Yuan asked, "Excuse me, but what do you mean by official match? I don't remember accepting any matches."

The sect elder standing outside then pulled out a logbook and pointed at his name that was written on one of the pages, "Is this not you?"

Yuan looked at the logbook.

"Outer Court Disciple Yuan versus Outer Court Disciple Wu Laohu."

"That is indeed my name, but I don't recall agreeing to any matches." Yuan was baffled to see that unreasonable disciple's name next to his name.

And he wondered, 'How did he even learn my name? I don't remember giving it to him!'

Unbeknownst to Yuan, whenever a disciple challenges another disciple to a deathmatch, regardless if the challenge is accepted or not, their names will be recorded in a jade slip at the Dispute Hall so the sect elders can keep watch of them, and that's how Wu Laohu learned of his name.

"I don't know your situation, Disciple Yuan, but it's an official match, and if you don't participate tomorrow, you'll be punished according to the sect rules." The sect elder said, thinking to himself that Yuan must be backing out after agreeing to fight Wu Laohu.

"Is there no way to cancel the match?" Yuan asked, as he really didn't feel like fighting without any reason.

The sect elder shook his head and said, "After your name is written in the logbook and a sect elder stamps it, you must participate in the fight no matter what. However, if both you and Wu Laohu agree to end the match, we can stop it."

'Haaaa... I doubt that person will agree to stop the fight, especially since he was the one who started it.' Yuan sighed inwardly.

Xiao Hua's voice suddenly resounded inside his head, "Brother Yuan, just accept the challenge and fight him. That disciple is the type of people who won't give up until the bitter end, so it's better to just give him what he wants. You'll take care of him easily, anyways."

'Since I have no choice but to fight him, I guess so...'

Yuan then nodded, "I understand. I'll show up for the match tomorrow."

"Good. The match will begin at the peak of sunrise tomorrow morning." The sect elder said to him before leaving.

After returning to his room, Xiao Hua appeared and said, "Brother Yuan, there will be times when you must step onto the stage and fight even if there are no good reasons for it. That's just the cultivation world. You fight and fight and fight until nobody dares to fight you anymore."

"If you don't accept these challenges, people will think you're a pushover and continue pressuring and bullying you. That's why the best thing to do is to just fight them."

"Hmm..." Yuan laid on the bed and stared at the empty ceiling with a dazed look on his face.

"Thank you, Xiao Hua. I think I know what to do tomorrow." Yuan nodded.

"I'll see you tomorrow morning, Xiao Hua. I just logged on to speak with Feng Feng for a bit."

"Okay. Goodnight, Brother Yuan."

After Xiao Hua returned to the necklace, Yuan logged off and proceeded to cultivate until morning.

"Good morning, Yuan." Meixiu entered his room early in the morning already with breakfast prepared.

"Good morning, Meixiu."

Sometime later, Meixiu began feeding Yuan soup.

"What do you think? Does it suit your taste?" Meixiu asked.

"Yes."

After breakfast, Yuan said, "By the way, Meixiu, I have a way to get you to the Eastern Continent in just a few days. I'll let you know when it happens."

"I understand."

After cleaning up, Meixiu said, "The Young Lady should be here in half an hour."

"I have something to take care of in Cultivation Online so I won't be able to greet her when she arrives," Yuan said.

"I understand. I'll notify the Young Lady."

Sometime later, Yuan went into Cultivation Online whilst Meixiu waited for Yu Rou's arrival.

Once Yuan returned to his room in the Dragon Essence Temple, he left the house and made his way to the sparring area where matches between disciples are held almost every day whether it be deathmatches or just casual sparring.

About twenty minutes later, Yuan arrived at the area, and to his surprise, there was already a large crowd there with all of them surrounding a large

platform.

"I heard Mad Tiger's opponent was too scared to show up yesterday?"

"That's right. We waited for the entire day and the bastard never showed up despite agreeing to this fight! What a spineless coward!"

"Then how do we know he'll be showing up today?"

"Apparently one of the sect elders spoke with him last night and confirmed that he will be showing up today."

"I see..."

While the disciples made fun of Yuan for not showing up yesterday, Yuan approached the stage that had two people on it— Wu Laohu and a sect elder.

"Look who decided to finally show up?! Did you finally stop shitting your pants?!" Wu Laohu laughed out loud when he noticed Yuan's approaching figure.

The disciples there quickly turned to look at Yuan's handsome face, even making a path for him so he could enter the stage.

A few moments later, Yuan stepped onto the large stage and stood a couple of meters away from Wu Laohu.

"Where were you yesterday?" The sect elder looked at Yuan with a frown on his face.

"I didn't know I had a match yesterday because I never agreed to fight him," Yuan responded in a calm voice.

The sect elder coldly snorted at his words and said, "Bullshit. I personally witnessed you agreeing to the fight, yet you dare claim that it never happened? I didn't know you were this shameless."

Yuan frowned at the sect elder's words. Was he involved in this scandal as well?

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Chapter 241 - Im Gonna Make An Example Out Of You!

Chapter 241 - I'm Gonna Make An Example Out Of You!

"Disciple Yuan, right? I can still forgive you for your audacious behavior if you kowtow before me and beg for forgiveness." Wu Laohu laughed out loud in a provocative manner.

However, Yuan remained calm and said, "If you fight every person that you bump into, you'll eventually bump into the wrong person and regret it."

Yuan's words wiped the smile off Wu Laohu's face, and Wu Laohu sneered, "I changed my mind. Even if you beg for forgiveness, it's already too late. I'm going to beat you until even your mother won't recognize you!"

"Elder Cheng, you can start the match!"

Elder Cheng nodded and said, "The rules for this match are simple— you fight until either one of you faints!"

The disciples were shocked when they heard the rules. Normally, one can end the fight by surrendering or leaving the stage, but according to Elder Cheng's words, they only lose when one of them loses consciousness! Isn't this basically a death match but without the death part?

"What? I have never seen such rules before! Did Elder Cheng and Mad Tiger plan this fight? I have heard rumors of it happening before as well!"

"Shhh! Don't let them hear you or you'll be on the stage next!"

Yuan's eyebrows twitched when he heard these disciples' whispers. Apparently, this isn't Wu Laohu's first time doing something like forcing another disciple to fight him.

'Why am I not surprised?' Yuan sighed inwardly.

"This is the true nature of the cultivation world, Brother Yuan. People will do whatever they can to achieve their goals." Xiao Hua's voice resounded inside his head.

Elder Cheng then continued, "Weapons are allowed in this match, but you are not allowed to use treasures! Furthermore, you are not allowed to kill each other!"

Elder Cheng looked at Wu Laohu as he said the last sentence, almost like it was specifically meant for him!

After all, even though he can help Wu Laohu rig a match, he won't be able to save him if he kills another disciple.

Seeing Elder Cheng's gaze, Wu Laohu showed a smile that said, "Don't worry, I won't kill him."

Elder Cheng nodded. He then turned to look at Yuan and said, "Are you ready to fight?"

"I am," Yuan responded calmly.

Wu Laohu retrieved an ordinary sword from his storage pouch and swung it around a few times with excitement in his movements.

Meanwhile, Yuan simply stood there without moving a single finger. Since he couldn't use treasures, all of his weapons were restricted. With that being said, he never planned on using a weapon to begin with.

"Does that disciple intend on fighting Mad Tiger without a weapon?! He's a madman!"

The disciples were dumbfounded when they saw this, and they couldn't tell if it was arrogance or stupidity.

Wu Laohu frowned when he saw this, thinking that Yuan was looking down on him.

"Hmph! As if I need a weapon to best your ass! In fact, I can beat you even more without a weapon!" Wu Laohu tossed his sword back into the storage pouch a few seconds later.

Meanwhile, many meters in the distance, hidden from plain sight, an old woman wearing high-ranking sect elder robes watched the match with a smile on her face.

"The Sect Master told me to protect him, but he also told me to not interfere unless necessary. While I could have prevented this match from even happening in the first place, that wouldn't be fair to Disciple Yuan who wanted to experience life as a disciple, right?"

This old lady was a high-ranking sect elder who worked at the Dispute Hall. Even though she could've stopped Wu Laohu and Elder Cheng from rigging this match, she purposefully allowed this match to continue so that Yuan could experience the true nature of the cultivation world and sects where unfairness is in every corner.

While the Dragon Essence Temple tries its best to keep certain things fair for the disciples, they only keep it to a minimum as a way to teach the disciples the laws of the jungle and prepare them for the outside world where everything is much worse.

Once both disciples were ready, Elder Cheng left the stage and said, "You may now begin the match!"

Immediately after Elder Cheng's words ended, Wu Laohu kicked his feet and rushed at Yuan with a bloodthirsty look on his face.

"I'm gonna make an example out of you and show the others what happens when you offend me, Mad Tiger Wu Laohu!"

Once he was close enough, Wu Laohu began clawing his hands at Yuan like a tiger relentlessly.

"..."

However, to the disciples' surprise, Yuan casually dodged every strike with a graceful movement technique they have never seen before.

"What kind of movement technique is that?!"

"I don't know, but look at his feet! You can see a trail of flames wherever he moves!"

"I guess this disciple has some ability, after all!"

The disciples were excited to see Yuan holding his own ground, but some of them still wanted to see a beatdown.

"Is that all you can do?! Dodge?! Fight me!"

Wu Laohu began getting irritated after a couple of minutes, feeling as though he was fighting an invisible enemy who he cannot hit.

Yuan remained silent as he continued dodging Wu Laohu's strikes.

A few more moments later, Yuan suddenly said, "I didn't want to fight, but you forced my hands."

Suddenly, Yuan disappeared from Wu Laohu's view and distanced himself.

"Where do you think you're going?!" Wu Laohu quickly turned around and chased after Yuan.

However, before he could even take two steps, Wu Laohu suddenly stopped moving and stood there like a statue, puzzling the spectators.

Meanwhile, Yuan stood there with a cold expression on his face, his eyes glowing brightly with a golden color as he activated Dragon's Gaze for the first time.

"T-This is..."

Wu Laohu's body trembled uncontrollably after seeing Yuan's golden eyes that emitted a feeling of absolute dominance.

Under the effects of Dragon's Gaze, Wu Laohu suddenly felt as though the entire world had darkened and the passage of time had stopped, and the only thing he could see was these two glowing eyes in the distance that were threatening his very existence!

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Chapter 242 - There's No Surrendering In This Match

Chapter 242 - There's No Surrendering In This MatChapter

After activating Dragon's Gaze for the first time since he learned it, Yuan continued to stare at Wu Laohu like a predator staring at its prey.

Since he could not use his treasures, nor did he intend on using any weapons, this was the only way he could deal with Wu Laohu without gravely injuring him.

"W-What's happening to Mad Tiger? He suddenly stopped moving!"

"Look at his face! It's twisted with fear for some reason!"

"What?! How is that possible?!"

The disciples and Elder Cheng there turned their heads to look at Yuan, and to their surprise, when they saw his golden eyes, their bodies trembled with profound fear despite not being targeted by the terrorizing gaze.

'What kind of terrifying technique is that?! I have never experienced such fear in my life— not even when I nearly died that one time!' Elder Cheng could feel his legs shaking uncontrollably, almost like there was an ongoing earthquake.

While the disciples and Elder Cheng were quaking in their boots by the unfathomable aura emitted by the Dragon's Gaze, Wu Laohu, who was directly targeted by this gaze, felt a hundred times worse, almost as though he was staring at a divine beast at this moment.

'What am I looking at? Why is everything so dark? Where am I? Who... am I?'

As though he'd lost his mind, Wu Laohu began questioning his own existence.

Shhhhh...

Unbeknownst to Wu Laohu, he'd pissed his pants, creating a yellow puddle underneath his feet and shocking the crowd. In fact, even after pissing his pants, Wu Laohu remained oblivious to that fact, as he was too fearful to notice anything.

Furthermore, he didn't dare to look away from Yuan's threatening gaze even for a split second, as he feared that if he looked away, Yuan would immediately kill him.

"You forced my hand."

Yuan suddenly said, startling Wu Laohu.

"W-What did you just say...?" Wu Laohu mumbled in a low voice.

"I said... this is all your fault."

BOOM!

Yuan's aura suddenly exploded, and his eyes began glowing even more brightly!

"Amazing! He's releasing an aura that's similar to Spirit Warriors but he's only at the peak of Spirit Apprentice!"

The disciples were shocked by Yuan's sudden display of prowess.

Cough!

Unable to bear Yuan's Dragon's Gaze any longer, Wu Laohu coughed up a mouthful of blood, staining the marble floor red. However, he didn't fall unconscious just yet and is barely holding on!

"If you didn't provoke me, none of this would have happened. If you didn't force this match, I wouldn't need to do this." Yuan spoke in a calm voice as he began moving again, making his way towards Wu Laohu.

"S-S-Stay away from me..." Wu Laohu spoke with a terrified voice, feeling a strong desire to turn around and run away, yet he remained standing there, rooted in fear.

Before he realized it, Yuan was already standing in front of him like a towering giant!

"P-Please... I-I forfeit! I surrender this match!" Wu Laohu shouted out loud, sounding like he was beginning for his life.

However, Yuan calmly resounded, "Surrender? Did you forget? There's no surrendering in this match. It'll only end when one of us loses consciousness."

The moment his sentence ended, Yuan increased the intensity of his Dragon's Gaze, pressuring Wu Laohu even more.

Cough!

Wu Laohu coughed up another mouthful of blood, feeling his vision becoming blurry.

"Perhaps... I should just kill you right here and right now so you will never be able to bother me again..." Yuan spoke in a cold voice, his eyes narrowing slightly.

"W-What?!" Wu Laohu's eyes widened with shock, and he could feel bloodlust coming from Yuan's gaze.

'He's not bluffing! He'll really kill me!' Wu Laohu thought to himself.

Unfortunately for Wu Laohu, due to the influence of Dragon's Gaze, he was in no condition to think logically, hence why he forgot about the sect rules regarding disciples killing another disciple.

"Die!"

Yuan activated Dragon's Gaze to almost full power, sending Wu Laohu into shock.

"Ah!"

Wu Laohu's eyes rolled behind his head with his body falling backward.

Thud!

Wu Laohu's body collapsed onto the floor a moment later with foam coming out of his mouth.

"..."

The entire place turned dead silent when they realized what had just happened.

"Mad Tiger lost consciousness! It's that disciple's win! He defeated the 3rd ranked Outer Court disciple without lifting a single finger!" One of the disciples there exclaimed after a moment of silence.

After defeating Wu Laohu, Yuan closed his eyes and rubbed them for a few seconds. Once he reopened his eyes, they returned to normal.

"This is my win, right?" Yuan turned to look at Elder Cheng and spoke.

"Gulp!"

Elder Cheng swallowed nervously as a chill went down his spine. Even though Yuan was no longer using Dragon's Gaze, Elder Cheng's body subconsciously reacted even to Yuan's gaze.

'J-Just who is this Outer Court disciple?!' he cried inwardly.

"Hahahahaha!"

Suddenly, a burst of loud laughter resounded in the area, causing everybody there to turn around, and to their surprise, an old lady was approaching the arena.

"Who is that sect elder?"

The Outer Court disciples there were unfamiliar with this old lady's appearance.

However, Elder Cheng's eyes widened with shock when he saw this old lady, as there was no way he'd not recognize the person he's working for—his boss!

"Senior E-Elder Dai!" Elder Cheng immediately bowed to her.

Elder Dai stopped in front of Elder Cheng and spoke in a calm voice, "Elder Cheng, what's going on here?"

"N-Nothing out of the ordinary, Senior Elder Dai. It's just two Outer Court disciples sparring with each other." Elder Cheng responded with a stiff smile on his face.

"Oh? Is that so?" Elder Dai nodded with an oblivious look on her face, acting as if she didn't know any better.

And she continued, "You may return to the Dispute Hall. I'll handle things from here."

"You will?" Elder Cheng looked at her with a gawking expression. Why does she, a high-ranking sect elder, want to handle something like a match between two Outer Court disciples?

Chapter 243 - Becoming Famous In The Outer Court

"Do I have to repeat myself?" The calm look on Elder Dai's face suddenly turned cold, causing Elder Cheng to tremble.

"N-No! I will leave this to you, Senior Elder!" Elder Cheng bowed to Elder Dai again before leaving the area in large strides.

Once Elder Cheng was gone, Elder Dai looked at the Outer Court disciples and said, "Someone bring me a bucket of cold water. Now."

Immediately after Elder Dai's words, most of the disciples there scrambled to get a bucket of cold water.

While they waited for the water, Elder Dai looked at Yuan and asked him, "That was a marvelous display of technique. However, why didn't you strike him? It would've ended much sooner if you'd just knocked him unconscious with your fists."

After a moment of silence, Yuan spoke in a calm voice, "Because I was taught that intimidation works better than violence. Even if I'd beaten him, I don't think he will give up, and he will eventually come to bother me again."

"Is that so?" Elder Dai nodded.

"Anyways, congratulations on defeating Wu Laohu who was ranked 3rd. Since you defeated him, you'll now replace his spot as third."

Meanwhile, somewhere within the Outer Court, on the Outer Court disciple's Power Ranking, Wu Laohu's 3rd place was replaced by Yuan's

name before being pushed down to the 4th place, shocking the disciples that were there to witness this change.

"Disciple Yuan? Who's this? I don't recognize this name! Where the heck did he come from?! Defeating that Mad Tiger is no easy feat!"

A small uproar occurred within the sect on that day with Yuan's name spreading like a wildfire.

A few minutes after the disciples left to get a cold bucket of water, one of the disciples finally returned with a large bucket of cold water.

"Here you go, Senior!" The disciple handed the cold bucket to Elder Dai, who immediately went onto the stage and dumped the entire cold bucket on Wu Laohu's unconscious body.

Splash!

"Aaaaaah!"

Wu Laohu woke up screaming as though he was just having a nightmare.

"Where am I?!" He looked around with a dazed look on his wet face, clearly puzzled by his situation.

However, when he saw Yuan's handsome figure standing not far away, Wu Laohu recalled everything that had happened and immediately ran away.

"Ahhh! Monster! Get away from me! Help—!"

Before Wu Laohu could run very far, Elder Dai appeared in front of him and slapped him in the face, causing him to fall on the floor again.

"Looks like you're still quite healthy." Elder Dai said in a nonchalant voice, and she continued, "You're lucky this wasn't a deathmatch, young man. Come with me, I have a lot to say to you."

Although he was puzzled, Wu Laohu nodded regardless.

"Senior, I..."

Yuan suddenly spoke, but Elder Dai shook her head and interrupted, "You don't have to tell me anything. I know what happened. They forced this match upon you even though you didn't accept it. Don't worry, I will punish them according to the Sect Rules."

Hearing Elder Dai's words, Yuan nodded and said, "Thank you."

"Heavens! I was right! Wu Laohu and Elder Cheng actually conspired against this Disciple Yuan with this fixed match! What an unfair match!"

"Hahaha! But they still lost in the end! How hilarious!"

Sometime later, Yuan left the scene, and the other disciples also left shortly later to spread the news of Wu Laohu's miserable loss.

"What? Disciple Yuan? This is the first time I've heard of this disciple. Is he new?"

"A new disciple defeated that Mad Tiger? He must be a genius!"

"I heard he used some kind of eye technique that rendered Mad Tiger spineless with a single gaze! I wouldn't mess with this guy even if I had ten lives!"

"I was there to witness his eye technique! Shit! I am still getting chills down my spine just thinking about it, and it felt like I was looking at a powerful beast!"

Yuan's name spread across the Outer Court like wildfire, and within a single day, almost every disciple in the Outer Court had heard about his fight against Wu Laohu, becoming famous.

Meanwhile, in the Dispute Hall, Elder Cheng and Wu Laohu stood beside each other while they faced Elder Dai with nervous looks on their faces.

"Elder Cheng, did you really think I didn't know about your actions? Not just today—I have known about it since you rigged your first match." Elder

Dai said in a calm voice, dumbfounding Elder Cheng.

'Does this mean she doesn't intend on punishing me?' He wondered inwardly with a hopeful feeling.

"Do you know why I didn't even bother to punish you?" Elder Dai then asked him.

"N-No, I do not, Senior Elder." Elder Cheng quickly shook his head.

"Because the cultivation world is never fair. Things like this happen on a daily basis throughout the world, not just the cultivation world, and I really couldn't care less about it since it doesn't really affect the sect." Elder Dai said, and she continued, "However, like most situations in the cultivation world, it's not about whether you're caught or not."

Elder Dai narrowed her eyes and said in a cold voice, "It's about who you're doing it to."

"If you'd treated a nobody unfairly, who would care? Nobody would care even if the entire world knew. However, if you treated someone from the Legacy Family like how you treated Disciple Yuan today, what do you think would happen once word gets out?"

"Of course, I doubt anybody would be stupid enough to offend someone from the Legacy Family, but hypothetically, if you'd done that, everybody would call you out for it."

"Now returning back to the topic at hand. The main reason I will be punishing you two for your actions today is not because you were being unfair—it's simply because you'd picked the wrong person to offend." Elder Dai spoke in a calm manner.

"Elder Cheng, you are no longer a disciple of the Dragon Essence Temple as of this moment. As for Wu Laohu, you'll be punished with four years of confinement. If you have a problem with my decision, you may speak with the Sect Master. However, I highly advise you to just accept my punishment

and not speak with the Sect Master, who will definitely make your lives much more miserable."

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Chapter 244 - A Powerful Slap

"Y-You're going to kick me out of the sect?" Elder Cheng stood there with disbelief on his face.

"I-I have served this sect for over 50 years! How can you throw me away like trash for something like this?! If it's as you'd said, that my actions don't affect the sect that much, why must you give me such a severe punishment, Senior Elder Dai?! Just who is that Outer Court disciple?!"

"I don't really have anything else to say. If you want to challenge my decision, go ahead and speak with the Sect Master. However, don't say I didn't warn you." Elder Dai said in a casual manner before waving her hands.

"You may leave now. Ah, make sure you hand over your disciple identification token before you leave." Elder Dai said.

"I will speak with the Sect Master! Even though I am wrong for what I did, I don't deserve such a punishment!" Elder Cheng slammed his disciple identification token on the desk before walking out.

"What about you, Disciple Wu Laohu? Do you also want to challenge my decision?" Elder Dai turned to look at him.

However, Wu Laohu shook his head and said, "I... I accept my punishment. No, please punish me."

After the horror he'd experienced today and the embarrassment he'd shown, Wu Laohu would rather stay holed up in confinement for the next couple of years, hoping that the disciples would forget him by the time he reemerges, especially Yuan, who he prays to never run into again for the rest of his life.

Meanwhile, Elder Cheng left the Dispute Hall to look for the Sect Master.

"Hm? The Sect Master? He should be at the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower right now with the other Sect Masters." A fellow sect elder told Elder Cheng after being asked about Long Yijun.

"I see. Thank you."

While Elder Cheng proceeded to make his way towards the tower, the disciples at the tower began whispering to each other after hearing about the fight between Wu Laohu and Yuan.

"What? Wu Laohu was defeated by a new disciple? As if I'd believe that!"

"It's true! Look at the Power Ranking if you don't believe me! A disciple by the name of Yuan had taken his spot and pushed everyone else down a place!"

"What?!"

Once a small commotion occurred in the place, the news eventually reached the ears of Long Yijun and the others.

'What? Disciple Yuan fought a match against Disciple Wu Laohu? How come I'm not aware of this until after the fight ended?' Long Yijun immediately frowned.

Elder Xuan and the other high-ranking elders such as Elder Bai and Elder Xin turned to look at Long Yijun, as they were also clueless.

"Wu Laohu? Isn't that the rumored Mad Tiger who climbed to 3rd place after spending only 2 years in the sect? A new disciple defeated someone like him? This is interesting."

The other sect masters there also had their interests piqued when they heard this news.

"Sect Master Long, do you know this Disciple Yuan who defeated the Mad Tiger?" One of them even decided to ask him.

"No... I have no idea." Long Yijun shook his head.

"If even the Sect Master doesn't know of such a talented disciple, he must be fairly new to the sect! Hahaha! How lucky for the Dragon Essence Temple! Looks like you have picked up another rough gem!"

The guests there laughed out loud.

'You have no idea...' Elder Xuan smiled inwardly at their statement.

Sometime later, Elder Cheng arrived at the place and approached the Long Yijun with a sweaty face.

"S-Sect Master... This disciple would like to have a word with you..." Elder Cheng bowed to Long Yijun in a respectful manner.

Long Yijun raised his eyebrows at Elder Cheng's unexpected approach.

"Elder Cheng from the Dispute Hall, correct? What's the matter? Why are you sweating so much?" Long Yijun asked him with raised eyebrows.

"T-This is..."

Elder Cheng's legs trembled, feeling incredibly nervous at this moment, almost like there was someone suffocating him.

"This disciple seeks justice!" Elder Cheng managed to speak his mind by shouting out loud, even crying afterward.

This shocked the people there. What happened? Why does Elder Cheng look like a child running to his parents after being bullied?

Seeing this, Long Yijun turned to look at the other Sect Masters and said, "Please excuse me for a moment."

"Come with me." He then said to Elder Cheng before leaving the crowd to go somewhere more private.

"What happened?" Long Yijun asked him.

"T-This..."

Elder Cheng proceeded to explain how he'd wronged by forcing a match between two disciples and how Elder Dai wanted to punish him by throwing him out of the sect without mentioning Wu Laohu or Yuan's name.

"What? Elder Dai said that?" Long Yijun couldn't help but become surprised after listening to Elder Cheng.

Even if Elder Cheng had done exactly what he'd said, kicking him out of the sect for something like this was truly an overkill, especially if he'd worked at the sect for so many years.

However, just as Long Yijun was prepared to show Elder Cheng some pity by lowering his sentence, he suddenly recalled what the others were talking about not long ago, which immediately caused him to frown.

And in a low but cold voice, Long Yijun spoke, "Elder Cheng. Let me ask you something. What is the name of the disciple that you'd forced to fight in a match?"

"The name? I think his name was Yuan—"

Before Elder Cheng could even finish his sentence, Long Yijun roared with veins all over his forehead.

"YOU FUCKING FOOL!"

PAP!

A powerful slap suddenly flew across Elder Cheng's face, sending him flying high into the air and towards the crowd at the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower, greatly shocking them.

"What the heck?!" One of the Sect Masters there fell from his seat in a startled manner before staring at Elder Cheng's unconscious body that had suddenly fallen from the sky and landed in front of him like a corpse!

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Chapter 245 - Fake It Till You Make It

Elder Cheng's unconscious body falling from the sky had shocked everybody at the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower, immediately causing a scene there.

"E-Elder Cheng! What happened to you?!" Elder Xuan quickly went to check his pulses just to make sure he wasn't actually dead.

After confirming that Elder Cheng was alive, Elder Xuan released a sigh of relief.

"What happened? Where's Sect Master Long?" The other Sect Masters there wondered since Elder Cheng was seen following Long Yijun.

And as though their words had summoned the demon, Long Yijun could be seen approaching them from a distance, but there was something different about him compared to when he left.

When the Sect Masters and the other disciples there saw the rage on Long Yijun's face, they thought his parents had been murdered or something, causing their body to tremble uncontrollably.

"Sect Master! What's the matter? Why are you so angry?" Elder Xuan quickly approached Long Yijun.

"Hmph! Get this!"

Long Yijun quickly explained the situation to Elder Xuan without letting the others hear it.

"Elder Cheng did what?!"

Elder Xuan shook his head in regret, and all of the pity and worry he had for Elder Cheng disappeared in less than a second after learning what Elder Cheng had done to Yuan.

"Elder Bai!" Long Yijun suddenly called for Bai Ling, Disciplinary Hall's leader.

"Yes."

Elder Bai appeared beside him immediately.

"Toss Elder Cheng into the Confinement Chamber until we're done here! I'll deal with him later!" Long Yijun spoke in a demanding tone.

"Yes, Sect Master."

Elder Bai did not question Long Yijun and immediately went to pick up Elder Cheng before carrying him away, and the people there watched with gawking expressions on their faces.

"I apologize for the slight disturbance, fellow guests and disciples. Please, act as though nothing had happened just now." Long Yijun said to the people there with a smile on his face before walking back to his seat like nothing really happened just now, shocking the people even more.

'What the heck just happened?! Who was that sect elder and what did he do to piss Sect Master Long so much?!'

'As if I could forget such a scene just because you told me to! I probably won't ever forget the look on Sect Master Long's face for the rest of my life!'

Although the people there were extremely curious about the situation that had just occurred, nobody there actually dared to bring the topic up after seeing Long Yijun's fearsome demeanor just now— not even the Sect Masters from the other sects.

On the other hand, Long Yijun cursed inwardly, 'Fuck! Why are there so many people trying to offend Disciple Yuan?! It's almost like they're purposefully trying to chase him out of the sect with their scandalous behaviors! If I have to kick out every sect elder to keep Disciple Yuan safe until the Mystic Realm, I'll freaking do it!'

"Sect Master, while what Elder Cheng did was wrong, you should also calm down." Elder Xuan suddenly said to him. "Don't forget that it's Disciple Yuan's desire to experience sect life as a normal disciple, and for normal disciples, they experience these kinds of unfairness every day."

"..."

Long Yijun became somewhat speechless after hearing Elder Xuan's words. How could he have overlooked such a thing? If they keep on protecting Yuan from these unfair situations, he will never experience life as an ordinary Outer Court disciple, nor will he understand their struggles.

Therefore, unless it threatened Yuan's life, they shouldn't interfere with his life and let him deal with the problems by himself. Of course, once Yuan deals with the situation, they'll punish the offenders afterward.

"Thank you for the reminder, Elder Xuan. I nearly robbed him of what made him want to join the Dragon Essence Temple in the first place—experience." Long Yijun sighed.

At this moment, the 89th floor from the tower emitted a golden light, signaling that whoever was challenging the tower had managed to reach the 90th floor.

"Hahaha! Look at this, Sect Master Long. We're only at our second challenger and he's already managed to climb all the way to the 90th floor! At this rate, someone will defeat all 100 floors and we'll still have half of our disciples left!" One of the guest Sect Masters laughed out loud.

"Hmm? The 90th floor, huh? Not bad for someone who's supposed to be your sect's best disciple." Long Yijun responded in a casual manner, almost like he wasn't worried even in the slightest.

"Hmph! Act tough all you want now! I can't wait to see the desperation on your face when you have to hand over the Dragon Slaying Saber!"

Long Yijun smirked at such remarks and said, "Yes, I also cannot wait."

Meanwhile, after defeating Wu Laohu, Yuan returned to his room and laid on his bed, and he proceeded to stare at the empty ceiling with a dazed look on his face.

"It was much harder than I'd expected— acting like I did during the match," Yuan sighed out loud.

"Brother Yuan, what you did today is simply acting like a real 'Cultivator'." Xiao Hua said to him.

"A real Cultivator? What's the difference?"

"A real Cultivator won't let anything block their path— they will walk straight no matter what stands in their way. If a mountain blocks your path, you destroy that mountain. If an ocean blocks your path, you split that ocean. If another Cultivator blocks your path, you trample on that Cultivator. That's how the most successful and powerful Cultivators in this world behave, hence why they're called 'real Cultivators'." Xiao Hua explained to him.

"That's... very aggressive and unreasonable... I don't know if I want to become someone like that." Yuan sighed.

"Don't worry, Brother Yuan. You can become a true Cultivator even without being like that. As long as you know when and how to act like a true Cultivator, you'll be fine. If I recall correctly, there's this saying— fake it till you make it... You simply need to fake that character and hope people believe it."

"Hmmm..." Hearing Xiao Hua's words, Yuan turned silent to ponder again.

Chapter 246 - Picking Up Yu Rou

"I think I understand what I should do. Thank you, Xiao Hua. You're always helping me. If only there's something I can do for you." Yuan said.

"Xiao Hua is satisfied with just being around Brother Yuan." Xiao Hua quickly responded.

Sometime later, Yuan said, "I'll see you later, Xiao Hua."

"Goodbye, Brother Yuan."

Yuan logged off the game shortly later.

Once Yuan logged off, he could immediately feel two presence around him.

"Sorry for making you wait, Yu Rou," Yuan said to her.

"Don't worry about it. I just got here." Yu Rou responded.

"By the way, I spoke with Feng Feng, Yu Rou. I told her about your situation, and she's currently heading to Phoenix City to pick you up. She also told you to wait for her at the Golden Phoenix Bazaar."

"Wait. Today?" Yu Rou asked.

"Yes."

"Okay. Fortunately, I brought my console with me, so I can enter the game even though I am here." Yu Rou said.

Yuan then continued, "As for Meixiu, after helping Yu Rou meet with Xia Jingyi, she will come to the Western Continent to help you next, but you

need to let her know your location so that she knows where to go."

"I understand, Yu— Young Master," Meixiu said.

Sometime later, Yu Rou went into the 3rd bedroom to set up her console whilst Meixiu went into her own room, both of them entering Cultivation Online once they were prepared.

While Yu Rou went to meet Feng Yuxiang and Meixiu wandered around to find her location, Yuan remained in the real world to cultivate. Currently, his priority was to raise his cultivation as fast as possible so that his body could recover faster, and he still had a few days until the Inner Court disciple examination.

Meanwhile, after entering the game, Yu Rou began making her way towards the Golden Phoenix Bazaar.

Many minutes later, Yu Rou arrived at the Golden Phoenix Bazaar, and she proceeded to stand outside the street to wait for Feng Yuxiang.

When the guards saw this, they tilted their heads. Normally, one can't loiter around the Golden Phoenix Bazaar even if they are outside the street. However, since Yu Rou was quite the eye candy, they didn't want to drive her away and allowed her to stay there so they could look at her beauty.

"Looks like she's waiting for somebody. Do you think it's her boyfriend?" One of the two guards there asked.

"If it is, then that man is a damn fool," said the other guard, and he continued, "If she was my girl, I wouldn't make her wait so long. In fact, I'd even be here before sunrise."

"Do you want to go speak with her? Maybe you'll get lucky."

"I don't know man. You think I should?"

"I wouldn't be saying it if I didn't! Go get her!"

The guard nodded, and just as he prepared to approach Yu Rou, a burst of flames appeared in the sky before descending directly outside the Golden Phoenix Bazaar, shocking the guards and everybody there.

"T-That's Madam Feng! Madam Feng is back!"

The guards were greatly shocked by her appearance, as Feng Yuxiang's whereabouts had been unknown for a while now!

Many people could be seen running out of their stores in the Golden Phoenix Bazaar when they noticed Fang Yuxiang's aura, and they quickly approached Yu Rou and Feng Yuxiang.

"Where have you been, Madam Feng?! The city's Lord has been worried sick ever since you disappeared!"

"Madam Feng! Are you finally back at the Golden Phoenix Bazaar?!"

"I've missed you and your shop, Madam Feng! Please come back to us! The Golden Phoenix Bazaar is not the same without your presence! It feels empty!"

Feng Yuxiang looked at the people swarming them with a nonchalant expression on her face, and she spoke a moment later, "I am busy with other things, so no, I won't be returning."

"What?! What are you busy with, Madam Feng? Perhaps we can help you!"

"Yeah! We'll do everything in our power to help you accomplish your needs!"

Hearing their words, Feng Yuxiang coldly snorted and said, "None of you can help me. Just forget about it. I won't return to the Golden Bazaar Phoenix no matter what you say."

She then turned to look at Yu Rou and asked her, "Are you ready to leave?"

"Yes."

Feng Yuxiang then wrapped her arm around Yu Rou's waist before soaring towards the heavens.

"Madam Feng~~~~! Please come back to us~~~!"

Despite the desperate shouting from below, Feng Yuxiang ignored it and asked Yu Rou, "Red Pearl City, right? If we head to the Teleportation Device three cities away, we arrive at the destination in less than a day."

"Thank you, Senior Feng." Yu Rou said to her.

"You can call me by my nickname just like the Young Master." Feng Yuxiang said to her as she began flying away from Phoenix City.

While Feng Yuxiang and Yu Rou made their way towards Red Pearl City, Meixiu wandered around the area until she could see city walls in the distance.

Ding!

[You have discovered Tang City]

"Tang City, huh..."

However, since Meixiu was not really interested in Cultivation Online, she logged off after learning the name of her location.

"Yuan, are you awake?" Meixiu asked him after entering his room.

"Yes, what's the matter?" Yuan stopped cultivating and responded.

"I am in a place called Tang City."

"I see. I'll let Feng Feng know once she's finished helping Yu Rou."

"I understand."

"In the meantime, can you check my bank account to see how much money is left in there? The information is..."

After giving Meixiu his personal bank account information, Meixiu used her phone to look at his bank balance.

A few moments later, she spoke in a low voice, "Yuan... there's no money in this bank account. The balance is literally zero."

"W-What?!" Yuan exclaimed in a shocked voice.

Where did his money go? He doesn't recall spending any of it, either!

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Chapter 247 - A Year Ago

'I don't have any money in my bank account? How's that possible? I haven't touched it since I got it!' Yuan pondered for a moment before realizing something.

However, before he could even say anything, Meixiu spoke, "The statement says the money, all 242,690 dollars, had been transferred to another bank account last year..."

"Two hundred thousand? I guess I had more than just a couple of thousand inside. As for where the money went, I can only imagine that it was my parents who took them." Yuan sighed.

And he continued, "Although I don't know how much I actually earned during my professional days, they really don't intend on leaving anything for me even though I earned it, huh? And if they'd taken the money a year ago, that means they were already prepared to disown me at that time."

"..."

Meixiu was silent as she listened to Yuan's grumbling.

If she recalls correctly, not even mentioning the money Yuan had won from major competitions, his parents would earn millions of dollars every single time Yuan went on the stage to perform in front of an audience. In fact, the larger performances easily earned them tens of millions of dollars. It is safe to assume that Yuan was the Yu Family's golden goose, hence why his parents waited so long before officially abandoning him.

Furthermore, Yuan would perform almost every other day, and if he was not performing for an audience, he would be participating in competitions, and he did this for many years. One can safely assume that Yuan had earned the

Yu Family hundreds of millions of dollars if not billions when he was playing for them.

However, despite everything he's done and given them, the Yu Family discarded him when they deemed him useless, and even worse, they were shameless enough to take what little he had left, leaving him with literally nothing.

'Perhaps this is why they even adopted me in the first place— because they can dispose of me whenever they feel like it since I'm not their real son.' Yuan sighed inwardly.

"Anyway, since my parents have access to that account, I cannot use it anymore. I will need a new bank account. But how do I open one?" Yuan asked a moment later.

"We can ask the Young Lady once she's done with the game," Meixiu suggested.

"Okay."

Thus, Yuan returned to cultivating whilst Meixiu went to clean the house even though it was already pretty clean.

Many hours later, Yu Rou finally arrived at Red Pearl City with Feng Yuxiang.

"Thank you, Feng Feng." Yu Rou said to her as they landed in front of the city entrance, shocking the pedestrians and guards there.

"Don't even mention it." Feng Yuxiang said, and she continued, "Anyway, I will return to the Young Master's side now. But before I leave..."

Feng Yuxiang reached into her spatial ring and retrieved a small red pouch before handing it to Yu Rou.

"Take this. If you're ever in danger, just use the life-saving treasures inside."

"You don't have to..." Yu Rou hesitated to accept such precious treasures for free.

"It's okay. The Young Master cares for you very much, and he will be sad if anything happens to you."

After a moment of silence, Yu Rou reluctantly accepted the treasures. "Thank you, Feng Feng. I'll definitely repay you in the future."

Feng Yuxiang nodded before flying away, making her way back to the Dragon Essence Temple.

'Young Master's sister... she doesn't share the same bloodline as the Young Master...' Feng Yuxiang thought to herself as she soared in the sky.

After spending a few hours with Yu Rou, Feng Yuxiang couldn't help but probe Yu Rou's body with her spiritual energy, and to her surprise, she noticed that Yu Rou and Yuan belonged to a different bloodline!

Even without tasting Yu Rou's blood, as a phoenix and a Divine Beast, she has the ability to examine one's bloodline just by being in close contact with them, and while she was curious about their real relationship, Feng Yuxiang didn't dare to probe too deeply into their business.

'No wonder why the Young Master is extremely talented whilst his sister is somewhat lacking... So they weren't related in the first place...' Feng Yuxiang thought to herself.

While Yuan's presence radiated with overwhelming talents, Yu Rou, on the other hand, was only above average compared to the Cultivators of this world— at least that's how she appeared in Feng Yuxiang's eyes, which didn't make sense at first. But if they were not real siblings, that explained their disparity.

After arriving at Red Pearl City, Yu Rou logged off the game to let Xia Jingyi know.

"Jingyi? I have arrived at Red Pearl City." Yu Rou said to her over the phone.

"What? Already? That's super quick! How did you do it?" Xia Jingyi's surprised voice resounded shortly later.

"Let's just say I had a little assistance from a friend," Yu Rou chuckled.

"Anyways, it's already late, and we have school tomorrow, so let's play next weekend."

"Okay!" Xia Jingyi quickly said.

After hanging up the phone, Yu Rou went to knock on Yuan's door.

"Brother Tian, I have arrived at my destination, and Feng Feng is returning to your side now," she said to him.

"That's good," Yuan said.

"I'm going to prepare your dinner now." Yu Rou said.

"Wait for a second, Yu Rou. Before you go, I have something to tell you."

"What's the matter?" Yu Rou asked.

"Well... It's about my bank account... It's completely empty." Yuan said in a sighing voice.

"What?" Yu Rou stared at him with wide eyes.

Yuan then explained the situation to her.

After learning the situation, Yu Rou was greatly shocked, even disgusted by her parents' actions.

"How could they do something like this, much less to their own son?! That's your money! Something you earned! They have no right to take it

from you! And to think they did it last year! Completely shameless and disgusting!" Yu Rou exclaimed, immediately feeling enraged.

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Chapter 248 - Real

"It's okay, Yu Rou. Fortunately for us, your friend allowed me to stay here for free." Yuan said a moment later.

"Even if that's the case, their actions are inexcusable! It's like they're doing everything they can to ruin your life! How can they do that to their own children?! That's despicable!" Yu Rou sighed.

'Because I'm not really their child...' Yuan sighed, feeling a strong urge to reveal everything to Yu Rou at this moment, but he'd managed to resist such urges at the end.

"Anyways, what should we do now? That bank account is no longer safe, so I will need to put my money somewhere else." Yuan asked her a moment later.

"I can open up a new account for you tomorrow, brother. But until you have enough money, I will pay for your expenses," Yu Rou said.

"Are you sure?"

"Of course. How else are you going to pay for your food and other necessities? Although I'm not rich, I have more than enough to help you." Yu Rou said.

And she continued, "But you should really sell your in-game stuff as soon as possible, brother, as the value for gold in Cultivation Online has been decreasing lately since people are growing stronger, allowing them to grind gold at a faster rate, not to mention the number of new players joining the game everyday. It's not really bad right now since the game is still fairly new and the rich people are buying as much gold as they can to upgrade

their avatars, but every dollar counts, especially when the family is no longer supporting you."

"Hmm... How much are gold coins worth, anyway?" Yuan suddenly asked.

"Let me check real quick..."

Yu Rou proceeded to check on her phone.

"According to the most popular trading website right now, one gold is worth about 7 dollars, so it dropped a few bucks since the Wealth Leaderboards came out."

"Seven dollars for a single gold coin? That's very profitable, no?" Yuan said in a surprised voice.

If he has one million gold coins, that's about 7 million dollars in the real world!

"If you think about it, it's not easy to earn money in Cultivation Online, and it usually takes on average three to four hours for the average player to earn a single gold coin. Of course, if you're a powerful Cultivator who can fight high-level monsters, you can make much more by selling their materials and monster cores, but not many people are at that level. Even the top players just recently entered Spirit Warrior despite spending tens of millions of real-life money for Cultivation Online gold and treasures to boost their cultivations."

"Speaking of cultivation, what level are you at right now?" Yu Rou suddenly asked.

"Hm? Me? The peak of Spirit Warrior, about to enter Spirit Master." Yuan casually responded.

"Peak Spirit Warrior?!?!" Yu Rou's jaw dropped after hearing his words.

Yuan had managed to surpass the top players by almost an entire realm without spending a single penny? That's simply too crazy! Too

overwhelming! The difference was too vast! Even if the top players spend hundreds of millions, they probably won't be able to reach Yuan's level!

'If the world knew of Brother Tian's cultivation, they'd probably go crazy — even more than currently...' Yu Rou thought to herself.

"S-Since you're this powerful, it shouldn't be a problem for you to earn gold in Cultivation Online. However, there is something even more precious than gold, and that is raw materials and treasures." Yu Rou then said.

And she continued, "Let's say you have a million gold and a treasure worth one million gold. If you sold the gold coins, you'll only get 7 million. However, if you sell the treasure, people will definitely pay more— at least 30 percent more. After all, treasures are more unique than gold, so it's always better to sell resources and treasures."

"How much would a Divine-grade treasure sell for?" Yuan suddenly asked.

"Eh? Divine-grade? Do you intend on selling a treasure at that grade?" Yu Rou looked at him with a surprised expression.

"Yes. I obtained this Divine-grade zither after winning the competition, but I don't really need it, as I already have another zither." Yuan said.

"A Divine-grade instrument... The families with a music background will go crazy for that. But I'm not sure about the price since nobody has sold anything even close to this grade before..."

"What's the most expensive item that has been sold thus far? Xiao Hua sold a Heaven-grade with peak quality to an auction house for over 30 million gold coins before." Yuan said.

"T-Thirty million gold coins? That must be when you unlocked the Wealth Leaderboards. If you'd sold that in the market, you'd have earned at least 300 million dollars!" Yu Rou exclaimed.

"Well, yeah, but I don't really consider that my money since it was Xiao Hua's treasure that was sold," Yuan said.

"If you sell the Divine-grade zither, you can easily get half a billion dollars, Brother Tian! That's more than enough to support yourself for many years! Are you going to sell it?" Yu Rou asked him.

"Yes. I plan on selling it. But how do I go about selling something so precious?"

"Indeed, you cannot sell something that precious in an ordinary market. However, I know just the place for expensive treasures—the auction house!" Yu Rou said.

"You can place the zither in an online auction house with a minimum starting price and the highest bidder gets to buy it."

"How will the trade work? Do I give them the treasure before or after they pay? Either way, this doesn't seem safe." Yuan said.

After all, what if the buyer just logs off the game after receiving the item without paying? How can you chase the scammer, much less get your items back? Wait for them to log back on and kill them?

"Don't worry, brother. Although it's not perfect, there's a system in place for that." Yu Rou said, and she proceeded to explain to him about the system in more detail.

Chapter 249 - Officially Disowned

"Let me explain to you how the online auction house works." Yu Rou said, and she proceeded to explain.

"First, a seller will list the item in the auction house, and if the item exceeds a certain price threshold, a staff member from the website must verify the item before the treasure is allowed to be auctioned."

"Once the treasure is verified in-game by a staff member and the auction begins, verified accounts will be allowed to bid on the item."

"At the end of the auction, the player with the highest bid will deposit the money on the website which cannot be touched until the transaction is completed or canceled."

"Once the staff member confirms the money is there, the seller will meet a staff member in-game and hand the treasure to the staff member."

"After the website confirms that the treasure is indeed the real thing, they will proceed to transfer the money to the seller's bank account before handing the treasure to the buyer, completing the transaction."

"I know there are some obvious flaws with this system, such as the staff member working together with others to scam the seller or vice versa, but that hasn't happened yet, and the website itself is very popular and reliable with millions of dollars in transaction every day, so I doubt they would risk their reputation over a treasure. In fact, even the government is watching them closely, so they won't do anything stupid."

"I see... Then let's do that." Yuan said.

"Okay. I'll create an anonymous account for you when I get home later." Yu Rou said.

"Thank you."

Sometime later, Yu Rou went to cook dinner whilst Meixiu assisted her.

After feeding Yuan, Yu Rou went back home to create an account for Yuan.

"Let's see... Register a new account..."

"Anonymous..."

"Seller..."

"Current location... Eastern Continent..."

"Complete."

After spending a few minutes on the website, Yu Rou created an anonymous account for Yuan, so that people won't see his player name when he sells things in the auction house. Of course, it would be better for one to show their name, especially if they're a top player, as that would give them more credibility.

"Good. Now I just need to wait until Meixiu meets with Brother Tian so that we can begin earning some money." Yu Rou chuckled.

If Yuan seriously wanted to earn money through real-world trading, he could easily become one of the richest players in this world with the stuff he currently has. However, knowing her brother, he probably doesn't care much about fame or wealth.

Just as Yu Rou prepared to enter her bed to sleep, her phone began ringing.

A frown appeared on Yu Rou's face when she saw the caller, but she picked it up regardless.

"Hello, mother."

"I'm tired of waiting. What's his decision?" Tang Lee spoke in a cold voice.

"Brother... I tried to convince him, but he refuses to play the instruments again..." Yu Rou responded in a nervous voice.

"Damn! That fucking useless piece of shit! How dare he defy us after all that we've done for him?! If it weren't for us, he would have remained as a nobody! If it weren't for us, he wouldn't have survived this long in his condition! Good! If this is his decision, then he can get the hell out of my family! I doubt he'll even survive a week in that condition without our support!"

"..."

Hearing her mother's enraged voice and insults towards Yuan, Yu Rou's body trembled in anger, and she tightly gritted her teeth, resisting her urges to curse Tang Lee out loud.

"Furthermore, I forbid you from meeting him from now on! He's officially disowned! Therefore, he's no different than a stranger now!" Tang Lee suddenly said.

"What?! T-That's unreasonable, mother!" Yu Rou immediately said in a panicked voice, her voice even cracking a bit from shock.

"Shut up! As long as you're part of this family, you will listen to us! Unless you want to follow in your brother's footsteps and leave the family, don't you dare talk back to your parents! Do you understand me?!"

"I..."

Yu Rou wanted to rebel at that moment and follow Yuan's decision by leaving the family. However, she ultimately resisted her impulses. After all, even if she cannot see Yuan anymore, she can still help him from the shadows. However, if she left the family, she will no longer be able to help Yuan in case of emergencies.

Furthermore, she's still a minor who has to attend school. It was unrealistic and irresponsible for someone like her to suddenly leave the family.

"Well?! I don't think I heard your answer, Yu Rou!" Tang Lee's voice resounded again.

"I understand, mother... I will no longer see Brother Tian..." Yu Rou responded in a pained voice, as she never thought that she would one day utter such words.

"I don't want to hear that useless thing's name anymore, either!"

Sometime later, Tang Lee closed the connection.

"..."

After hanging up, Yu Rou tossed her phone on the bed before burying her face in the pillow and bawling her eyes out until she cried herself to sleep a few hours later, soaking the pillow with her tears.

Early in the morning, Yu Rou woke up before sunrise as usual. Since she has been waking up at the same time almost every day for the past few years to take care of Yuan, her body would instinctively wake up.

However, after remembering that Yuan was no longer part of the family, Yu Rou closed her eyes and went back to sleep, but to nobody's surprise, she was unable to go back to sleep.

"I'm sorry, brother, for being so powerless..." she mumbled in a dispirited voice.

Once it was time for school, despite having no motivation or energy to leave the bed, Yu Rou struggled with herself until she was in the car.

Sometime later, Yu Rou went to pick up Meixiu at the apartment.

"Did something happen, Young Lady? Your eyes are red, and you look exhausted... Did you not sleep last night?" Meixiu asked her in a worried tone after seeing her messy appearance.

"I'll explain everything later..." Yu Rou sighed.

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Chapter 250 - Desperation And Passion

After struggling to pay attention and stay awake in her classes, Yu Rou managed to endure until lunchtime.

"Sister Rou, did something happen to you? I noticed that you were dozing off during class. This is unprecedented..." Xia Jingyi asked her after they sat down for lunch.

"It's a long story..." Yu Rou sighed.

"If you don't want to say it..."

"No, I'll tell you, since you're somewhat related now." Yu Rou said, and she proceeded to explain to them what had happened yesterday and how her mother forbade her from seeing Yuan.

Cough! Cough!

"What?!" Xia Jingyi almost choked on her drink after listening to Yu Rou, and she slammed the desk in anger.

"How can she do that to you and your brother— her own children?! I have never seen such despicable people before! Ah... I'm sorry for yelling at your parents, Sister Rou, but I just can't remain calm after hearing what they did..." Xia Jingyi said.

"Don't worry about it, Xia Jingyi. I also feel that what my parents did is unforgivable! However, there's nothing I can do, and it's not like I could just leave the family. If I was even half as talented as Brother Tian, perhaps

I would have some saying in the family, but alas, that's not the case." Yu Rou sighed.

While it's true that Yuan could support both of them if he begins real-world trading, there are things in this world that cannot be solved even with money. Furthermore, she doesn't intend on letting Yuan take care of her forever. If anything, it should be the other way around— she should be taking care of him! However, she can't do that if she leaves the family, and the biggest problem is that she's still a minor, whilst Yuan is considered an adult.

"What are you going to do now, Sister Rou?" Xia Jingyi asked her a moment later.

"I honestly don't know, but we can only continue with our plans and see how it goes. If things don't work out, we will think of something else." Yu Rou said.

"If you need anything, just let me know, Sister Rou! I'll do my best to support you and your brother!" Xia Jingyi said.

"Thank you, Jingyi." Yu Rou said to her with a sweet smile.

"What should I do, Young Lady? If the Masters find out that I'm helping the Young Master, there's a good chance they'll also force me to stop." Meixiu suddenly said.

"You'll continue taking care of Brother Tian since there's nobody else we can trust right now. I'll try my best to keep your business a secret. If my parents find out... Once again, we'll think of something." Yu Rou said to her.

"I understand, Young Lady." Meixiu nodded.

Meanwhile, Yuan continued to cultivate in his room, reaching 3rd level Spirit Warrior an hour before Meixiu returned.

"Young Master... I mean, Yuan, I have something news regarding the Young Lady." Meixiu said in a solemn voice.

"Hm? Did something happen to Yu Rou?" Yuan asked in a worried voice.

"Well..."

After taking a deep breath, Meixiu explained to him the situation, how he's officially disowned and kicked out of the Yu Family and how they forbade Yu Rou from seeing him anymore.

"Yu Rou can't see me anymore...?" Yuan mumbled in a dazed voice.

After taking longer than necessary to understand the meaning behind such words, mostly because he was shocked, Yuan gritted his teeth in anger.

"I don't care if they take away all of my possessions and money. I don't even care if they kick me out of the family. However, to think they'd stoop as low as this...! They're clearly using Yu Rou to purposefully piss me off!"

Yuan subconsciously tightened his hands to make a fist at this moment despite not feeling them, and his fingers trembled a bit, moving more than usual.

"..."

Due to her attentiveness, Meixiu did not miss this slight movement and nearly cried out loud of shock after seeing it.

'I... I wasn't imagining things just now, right? Yuan... his fingers... it moved!' Meixiu cried inwardly, unsure how much of what she just witnessed was real or just her imagination.

However, after rubbing her eyes and looking again, she couldn't see Yuan's fingers moving anymore.

'Perhaps it really was just my imagination?' she wondered.

"I swear... if they made Yu Rou cry just to get back at me!" Yuan said, experiencing an indescribable feeling of rage in his heart that felt similar to heartburn.

Dub! Dub! Dub!

Yuan could feel his heart racing, unaware of the flame in his heart that was expanding larger and fiercer.

Feeling a subtle but suffocating atmosphere suddenly appear in the room, Meixiu spoke in a nervous voice, "I... I am going to prepare dinner now."

And she quickly escaped the room, immediately feeling better after leaving Yuan's room.

'What was the feeling just now?' Meixiu wondered to herself as she wiped the cold sweats off her forehead.

Meanwhile, Yuan tried his best to calm down, but alas, it was much more difficult than he'd expected.

'I thought only the cultivation world would have such unreasonable people, but it appears that such people exist in this world as well, and they even used to be my own parents!' Yuan sighed inwardly after realizing this fact.

Unfortunately, unlike Cultivation Online where he has many powerful supporters, he could only rely on Yu Rou and a few other people in this world. Furthermore, his movements are extremely limited, making it impossible for him to do anything about this situation.

'If only I could move! If only I am not so useless in this world!' Yuan gritted his teeth in frustration.

'The only thing I can do right now is to improve my cultivation!'

With this thought in mind, Yuan began cultivating again despite the unpleasant feeling in his heart that is desperation mixed with passion.

A few moments later, a gentle breeze appeared in the room as Yuan's cultivation speed suddenly increased even more, but alas, he was too focused to notice this change.

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Chapter 251 - Soul Techniques

After cooking dinner, Meixiu went back into Yuan's room to feed him. However, she was a little bit nervous to enter his room at first, fearing that uncomfortable atmosphere that still lingered in her body.

Yuan stopped cultivating the moment he noticed Meixiu standing in front of his room.

Sometime later, Meixiu began feeding Yuan three bowls of soup.

After Yuan gobbled down all three bowls of soup with ease, Meixiu gently wiped his lips with a wet towel.

"Allow me to wipe your body now," said Meixiu in a somewhat shaky voice.

"Okay."

Meixiu proceeded to unbutton Yuan's customized pajamas and began wiping his body down with a warm wet towel.

'His body... It's even more refined and muscular than last time... Just how does his body work?' Meixiu wondered to herself as she wiped every nook and cranny of his body before moving to the lower areas.

Meixiu swallowed nervously as she carefully wiped his lower body, trying her best to avoid another accident like last time.

A few minutes later, Meixiu buttoned his clothes back up before leaving the room to clean up.

Meanwhile, Yuan returned to cultivating.

After cleaning the dishes and taking a shower, Meixiu visited Yuan one more time before bed to see if he needed anything.

"Goodnight, Meixiu."

"Goodnight..."

Once Meixiu went to sleep, Yuan began absorbing the spiritual energy in the area.

'Is it because we're living in a higher place that there's more spiritual energy here?' Yuan wondered to himself as he realized that compared to his old home, the spiritual energy in this place was more abundant.

One hour... Two hours... Three hours...

Time passed in a flashing speed as Yuan deeply indulged himself in his cultivation, achieving another breakthrough and reaching 4th level Spirit Warrior.

'At this rate, I'll catch up to my cultivation in Cultivation Online...' Yuan thought to himself.

'Wait a second...'

Yuan suddenly came to a realization.

'If I could use Divine Sense when I am only a Spirit Warrior in Cultivation Online, perhaps I'll also be able to Divine Sense in this world with my current cultivation?'

Yuan could feel his heartbeats quickening immediately after this thought.

What if he can use Divine Sense to see again? This way, even if he cannot move, he can at least see his surroundings.

With this thought in mind, Yuan immediately began trying to use Divine Sense.

'Let's see... Divine Sense...'

Yuan tried to replicate the feeling he gets when he uses Divine Sense in Cultivation Online, but after trying for a couple of minutes without any results, Yuan gave up for the moment.

'Why can't I use Divine Sense? Do I have to reach Spirit Master before I can use Divine Sense like Xiao Hua once said?' Yuan wondered to himself.

Just like how he couldn't immediately breakthrough to Spirit Warrior from Spirit Apprentice without enlightenment like he had in the game, perhaps he can't use Divine Sense until he's a Spirit Master either.

'Or maybe I'm just not used to Divine Sense enough to use it in the real world. I should practice in Cultivation Online after breakfast and try again later.'

Meixiu woke up early in the morning to prepare breakfast. After feeding Yuan, she went to school with Yu Rou whilst Yuan went into Cultivation Online to practice his Divine Sense.

"Xiao Hua, are there any tricks to learning Divine Sense?" Yuan decided to ask the expert before doing anything.

"Unfortunately, just like enlightenment, Divine Sense is something one naturally learns when they reach Spirit Master. Of course, there are geniuses who learn Divine Sense before that like Brother Yuan, these people are very rare." Xiao Hua said to him.

"I see... Then is there any way to practice Divine Sense to make it stronger?" He then asked.

"As long as you continue using it, you'll naturally improve. Though there are methods to training one's Divine Sense, and that is to cultivate Soul Techniques."

"Soul Techniques? How are they any different compared to normal cultivation techniques?"

"As the name suggests, Soul Technique specifically trains one's spirit and soul. However, these techniques are very rare and even the lowest rank Soul Techniques can be worth more than Heaven-rank cultivation techniques."

"What? They're that valuable?" Yuan was shocked to learn this.

"Of course. While it's relatively easy for a Cultivator to train their physical bodies and their cultivation bases, training their soul is an entirely different matter, and without the proper technique, there's a high chance of damaging their soul—a risk no sane Cultivator would dare to risk since a damaged soul usually means instant death with no chance of reincarnation." Xiao Rou said.

And she continued, "Training one's soul is a very delicate matter that requires extreme care and attention, as a single mistake could cost even an Immortal their entire life."

"Immortals and reincarnation? Do they really exist?" Yuan couldn't help but ask.

"While Immortals are definitely very real, reincarnation, on the other hand... There has been no solid evidence it exists. However, many if not most Cultivators believe in reincarnation," said Xiao Hua.

"I see... Thank you, Xiao Hua. I'll practice my Divine Sense the normal way since I don't have a Soul Technique and I don't feel like touching something that dangerous without more knowledge."

"Xiao Hua will help Brother Yuan." Xiao Hua said, and she continued, "Sit down and activate your Divine Sense."

Yuan nodded and followed her instructions.

Once he was seated in the lotus position, he closed his eyes and activated his Divine Sense.

"Now try to expand your Divine Sense until you can no longer expand it." Xiao Hua's voice resounded.

A few moments later, Yuan expanded his Divine Sense until he reached his limit, feeling like someone trying to stretch their arms without moving.

"Good. Now keep your Divine Sense like that until you can no longer endure it, Brother Yuan. This will improve your endurance and strength at the same time," Xiao Hua said to him like a lecturer.

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Chapter 252 - A Bored Face

Yuan followed Xiao Hua's instruction and kept his Divine Sense active and as far out as he could manage until he could no longer keep it up due to exhaustion.

"Haa... haaa... It's really tiring trying to maintain Divine Sense; it's much more exhausting than using cultivation techniques." Yuan said afterward while panting.

"That's obvious, Brother Yuan, since using Divine Sense requires more than just your spiritual energy, as it uses your mental strength as well. With that being said, Brother Yuan is only a Spirit Warrior whilst people normally unlock their Divine Sense as a Spirit Master. Compared to the others, Brother Yuan is already miles ahead."

Yuan nodded his head and rested until he recovered his mental and spiritual energy before he began training his Divine Sense again, and he repeated this process for nearly the entire day.

Just as Yuan prepared to log-off, Feng Yuxiang returned to the house.

"I'm back, Young Master!" Feng Yuxiang said, sounding like a family member after a long day at work.

"Welcome back, Feng Feng. Thank you for taking my sister to that location," Yuan said to her.

"Don't even mention it, Young Master. It's my pleasure to help you. After all, as long as this contract stands, my everything belongs to you." Feng Yuxiang said with a smile on her face.

And she continued, "What about your other friend who's in the Western Continent?"

"Oh, right. Her name is Meixiu, and she's currently at Tang City in the Western Continent."

"Tang City, right? Got it. What does she look like, Young Master? It'll make things much more convenient since I have never seen her before." Feng Yuxiang then asked.

"Uhh... How does she look...?" Yuan was speechless, as he hasn't seen Meixiu's appearance since he lost his eyesight over a decade ago!

Feng Yuxiang raised her eyebrows, and she spoke a moment later in a puzzled voice, "You don't know what your friend looks like, Young Master?"

"W-Well... It's been a very long time since I last saw her, after all." Yuan quickly thought of an excuse.

"Oh, I see. Then what do you remember about her?" Feng Yuxiang then asked.

"Hmm..."

Yuan closed his eyes to think, recalling Meixiu's features when she was young.

"She has this naturally bored-looking face, or more precisely, she always looks bored, almost like nothing in this world could entertain her. I think you'll immediately notice her since she really stands out." Yuan said as he recalled Meixiu's face.

"I-I see..." Feng Yuxiang nodded with a somewhat dazed expression on her face, as she didn't expect such an awkward description.

"Ah, she will be at the city entrance waiting for you." Yuan suddenly said.

"The entrance, right? I understand. I'll see you in a few days, Young Master. Stay safe." Feng Yuxiang said to him before turning around and leaving the house again.

Whoosh!

Two large and majestic flaming wings appeared behind Feng Yuxiang's back, and with a single flap of her wings, Feng Yuxiang soared many miles into the distance.

"See you tomorrow, Xiao Hua."

"See you later, Brother Yuan."

After logging off the game, Yuan immediately tried to use his Divine Sense, but alas, there were no results.

'I shouldn't expect immediate results. This could take days, even months before anything happens... However, no matter how long it takes, as long as there's a chance that I can see again...' Yuan motivated himself.

Sometime later, Meixiu returned home and began preparing dinner.

During dinner, Yuan said to her, "Meixiu, my friend Feng Feng is heading to the Western Continent right now, and she'll probably be there in a few days. If you have time, log into the game and see if she arrived yet."

"What does this friend of yours look like?" Meixiu asked.

"She's a really pretty lady with long black hair and brown eyes. She also wears red clothes that seem a little too small for her since it sticks to her skin." Yuan said as he recalled Feng Yuxiang's image in his head.

"Sticks to her skin...?" Meixiu raised her eyebrows, thinking that this person must be wearing a tight dress or something to show off her body but Yuan is too oblivious to realize it.

"I understand. I will check the game whenever I'm available." Meixiu then said.

After dinner, Meixiu went to do her own things whilst Yuan tried activating his Divine Sense again.

An hour later, Yuan gave up and went to cultivate instead.

The following morning, after Meixiu finished feeding Yuan breakfast, he went into the game while Meixiu went to school.

"Let's train my Divine Sense today as well!" Yuan sat down and quickly activated his Divine Sense with more determination than ever.

However, a few hours into his training, someone knocked on his door, forcing him to stop for the time being.

"Who could it be?" Yuan wondered to himself as he went to open the door.

Standing outside his doorsteps was a beautiful young lady with a familiar-looking face.

"Hello, Min Li. It's been a while." Yuan said to her.

"Hello, Disciple Yuan. I hope I'm not bothering you." Min Li greeted him back.

"No, you're fine. Do you need something?" Yuan then asked.

Min Li shook her head and said, "Nothing, really. I heard about what happened recently and how you defeated the 3rd strongest Outer Court disciple, taking his place in the Power Ranking. Congratulations."

"Although it wasn't my intention to fight him, thank you," Yuan said with a somewhat stiff smile.

"Disciple Yuan, you may be a Spirit Warrior and with extreme talents that this world has never seen before, but I won't give up on trying to catch up to you!"

Min Li said, and she suddenly released her aura, surprising Yuan.

"You managed to breakthrough to Spirit Warrior? Congratulations!" Yuan congratulated her in a sincere voice.

"T-Thank you..." Min Li felt embarrassed by his words for some reason and began blushing in response.

"A-Anyway, I'm going to return to my training now. I'll talk to you later, Disciple Yuan."

"Okay. See you." Yuan nodded.

Min Li then turned around and walked away.

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Chapter 253 - Inner Court Disciple Examination

After Min Li left, Yuan went back inside his house and returned to training his Divine Sense.

However, not even an hour later, he could hear the door being knocked on again.

"Who is it this time?" Yuan mumbled as he went to open the door.

"Are you Disciple Yuan?" A middle-aged woman wearing sect elder robes stood outside his door this time.

"Yes, I am." Yuan nodded.

"I am here to notify you that the Inner Court Disciple Examination will begin tomorrow morning, and you must be present at Jade Peak before sunrise or you'll automatically fail. Do you have any questions for me?"

"Jade Peak before sunrise, right? I will be there. Thank you." Yuan said to the sect elder.

The sect elder left the place shortly later.

After leaving Yuan's place, the sect elder sighed to herself, "This is my first time notifying a disciple in such a manner. What am I? Some kind of messenger? However, this is an order from a high-ranking elder, so I have no choice but to do it..."

Yuan returned to his room afterward, and he mumbled, "Inner Court disciple, huh? I kind of want to experience life as an Outer Court disciple

some more, but I don't really know if there's anything else I can do as an Outer Court disciple that an Inner Court disciple cannot do..."

"Brother Yuan is an abnormal existence. Even though you have the title of an Outer Court disciple, you don't really get treated like one, and you're already too powerful to experience the struggle that other Outer Court disciples must endure." Xiao Hua said to him.

"Is that so? But there's nothing I can do about that... What a pity..." Yuan sighed.

"Once Brother Yuan travels to the upper heavens where there are more geniuses, you might be able to experience the struggle some people go through— or not... since I highly doubt someone as talented as Brother Yuan would struggle in anything that's related to cultivation..."

"Anyways, I'll participate in this examination and become an Inner Court disciple tomorrow. For now, let's continue focusing on training my Divine Sense."

Thus, Yuan returned to his training.

Once the sun began setting, Yuan logged off the game and waited for Meixiu to return. Of course, he tried to activate his Divine Sense again but to no avail.

After dinner, he said to her, "Meixiu, I'm going to stay in the game tonight since there will be an event early tomorrow morning, and I don't want to wake you up earlier than you already do."

"It's fine. I don't mind. Your health is more important to me. When do you need to enter the game?" Meixiu asked him.

"Are you sure? I can just stay in the game. It's not my first time doing this, anyways. Of course, Yu Rou approved of this as well."

"If the Young Lady also allowed it then..." Meixiu said, then she continued after a brief pause, "What about breakfast? You'll miss breakfast at this

rate..."

"It's only one meal, I'll be fine. Furthermore, I'll be in the game, so I won't really feel any hunger."

"I understand. Then goodnight, Yuan."

"Goodnight."

After Yuan went inside the game, Meixiu went to do her own things before falling asleep.

Inside the game, Yuan proceeded to spend the entire night training his Divine Sense.

"Brother Yuan, your Divine Sense's range has increased by almost a dozen meters since you began training. At this rate, it won't be long before you surpass me, Brother Yuan." Xiao Hua said.

"You're exaggerating, Xiao Hua. It'll take me years before I can catch up to you..." Yuan sighed.

Xiao Hua looked at Yuan and blinked her eyes in a dazed manner.

If Yuan had managed to reach the peak of Spirit Warrior in just a few weeks as a mortal who has never cultivated before, one can only imagine what he could achieve in a few years! Perhaps he might even ascend to the highest heaven and stand at the peak of this universe!

Xiao Hua suddenly turned to look at the window and said, "Brother Yuan, it's almost sunrise."

"Oh, right! I almost forgot! Thank you for reminding me, Xiao Hua!"

Once Xiao Hua entered the necklace, Yuan made his way to the Jade Peak that was only a couple of minutes away if he ran.

Meanwhile, at the Jade Peak, there were already over a hundred Outer Court disciples gathered there, all of them preparing to take the Inner Court

Disciple Examination.

And just minutes before the sun fully rises, Yuan arrives at the Jade Peak, being the last person there. With that being said, since almost everybody there arrived hours earlier in advance with some even having slept there through the night in fear of missing the examination, Yuan was destined to be the last to arrive.

The other disciples there frowned when they saw Yuan arriving right before the deadline. In their eyes, it was because Yuan couldn't care enough about the examination, hence why he was acting so carefree.

"Che! Why is someone like that participating in the examination? He's looking down on all of us with his carefree attitude!"

"Right?! Look at his casual-looking face! It's like he's taking a stroll in a park or something!"

"Forget about him. People like that won't make it through half of the examination. In other words, he won't become an Inner Court disciple."

"Hmph! I have engraved his face into my soul! Just wait until I become an Inner Court disciple! I'll be sure to teach him a lesson or two about his behavior!"

To these Outer Court disciples that have trained for years and endured countless trials to reach this point, becoming an Inner Court disciple is something profoundly significant and honorable with the Inner Court Disciple Examination being the sacred path that will lead them to that position, and for someone to act so nonchalant in this sacred exam was a blasphemy, even a slap at their faces!

Chapter 254 - Increasing The Standards

After arriving at the Jade Peak, Yuan could already feel an unpleasant atmosphere in the air when he noticed the other disciples staring at him with frowns on their faces.

'They seem unhappy. Did something happen? Or are they just nervous about the examination?' Yuan wondered to himself, completely oblivious that they were angry at him for being on time, as that was completely unreasonable.

And while the other disciples only mumbled to each other, one of them was actually brave enough to approach Yuan and said loudly, "Hey! You! What's your name?!"

"Me? I'm Yuan," he calmly responded.

"Hm? Yuan? Why does that name sound so familiar?" The disciples there wondered when they heard Yuan's name.

"Oh, shit! He's that Outer Court disciple who defeated the Mad Tiger recently!" One of them quickly realized and exclaimed in a surprised voice, shocking the other disciples.

"What?! He's the new disciple who took Mad Tiger's 3rd place in the Power Ranking?! No wonder why he dares to act so carefree in the Inner Court Disciple Examination!"

The Outer disciples there immediately found Yuan's 'late' arrival to be more understanding now and felt less offended.

"He's a new disciple who only recently joined the sect, right? Why is he participating in the Inner Court Disciple Examination already? Even the top geniuses in our sect usually wait half a year before they decide to become an Inner Court disciple."

"Maybe he's just that confident. Who knows."

"Even though he's defeated the Mad Tiger, you cannot become an Inner Court disciple with just raw strength, after all."

While the disciples mumbled to each other, Yuan asked the disciple who spoke to him, "Do you need something from me?"

"Uh... N-No... I just wanted to know the names of those who will be participating in the examination with me... I'm sorry if I'd bothered you... And good luck..." The disciple acted very humbly after realizing that he was standing before the one who was said to have defeated the Mad Tiger without lifting a finger.

"I see. Good luck to you, too." Yuan nodded at the disciple who quickly turned around and walked back into the crowd.

A few seconds after Yuan gathered with the other disciples, the sect elder that went to Yuan's house to notify him of the examination appeared before them and said, "Hello, Outer Court disciples. I am Elder Tantai. Everybody here that is participating in the examination, follow me to the examination hall."

Once Elder Tantai turned around and began walking, the disciples there followed her like a group of ducklings.

Half an hour later, they arrived at the borders between the Outer Court and the Inner Court.

"That is the Examination Hall; it's where one comes out either as an Inner Court disciple or remains as an Outer Court disciple." Elder Tantai pointed at the massive stadium in the distance.

A few minutes later, they arrived at the large entrance to this place.

"Once we walk through these doors, whether you become an Inner Court disciple or not today, you will not enter these doors again for another year." Elder Tantai said.

If they become an Inner Court disciple, even if they are a cultivation genius, it will take them more than one year to even qualify to take the examination to become a Core Disciple. As for those who fail to become an Inner Court disciple today, they will have to wait another year before they can try the examination again.

Elder Tantai opened the door and walked inside.

Sometime later, they arrived inside the stadium that was shaped like a football field in the modern world; it was a vast and spacious one-mile long field inside with a couple of gates towards the end.

Once they were at the center of this field, Elder Tantai said, "For the examination, you will have to pass three tests."

And she continued, "For the first test, we will test your endurance by lighting an incense that has poisonous properties, and you must protect yourself with your spiritual energy until the incense is completely burned. Don't worry if you're infected by the poison, as we have antidotes prepared."

"For the second test, we will test your combat prowess with a Training Puppet. Use your strongest and most experienced martial skill on it."

"Lastly, we will have you fight against a real magical beast at the peak of Spirit Apprentice. Of course, you must defeat it in order to pass."

"Does anyone have any questions before we begin?" Elder Tantai then asked.

"What kind of poison is it, Elder?" Someone raised his hands and asked.

"Poison from a Weeping Serpent," said Elder Tantai without hesitation.

"What?! The Weeping Serpent?!"

The disciples were shocked when they heard this name, and some of them even began shaking in fear.

Poison from a Weeping Serpent can kill anyone below Spirit Warrior within seconds, and most of the people there were only peak Spirit Apprentice with a few that just entered Spirit Warrior!

What if they die before they even begin the second exam, much less become an Inner Court disciple?!

Furthermore, while they expected this sort of test since it has happened before in previous examinations, the sect has never used such a strong poison for the examination before! This is a first!

Seeing the fear on the disciples' faces, Elder Tantai said, "If you're too afraid of the poison, you may turn around and leave the Examination Hall. However, let me tell you, even if you come back next year, the poison won't get any weaker. In fact, it'll only grow stronger as time goes. The Dragon Essence Temple has decided to increase its standards for all disciples, after all."

The disciples' eyes widened with shock when they heard this. The sect increased its standards? Why would they suddenly do that when the sect has remained the same for thousands of years? What caused this change?

"You have ten seconds to decide whether you want to continue or not... Ten... Nine..."

Elder Tantai suddenly started the countdown, making the disciples panic even more.

Chapter 255 - Special Training

Puppet

"Three... Two... One..."

After ten seconds, to Elder Tantai's surprise, none of the disciples decided to leave the examination.

"Now then, let's continue with the examination, shall we?"

Elder Tantai placed a foot-long purple-colored incense stick into the ground and said, "I want everybody to sit around the incense stick."

The disciples followed her instruction, and a few moments later, all 121 disciples sat around the incense stick.

"The exam will officially begin once I light the incense stick. If you're poisoned, I will immediately apply the antidote, but you will automatically fail the examination."

The disciples swallowed nervously, and they watched as Elder Tantai lit the incense stick.

Once the incense stick was lit, purple smoke began to fill the area quickly, but Elder Tantai remained standing directly beside the poisonous incense stick without a care in the world.

Meanwhile, the disciples quickly began releasing their spiritual energy, covering their body with it so that the poisonous smoke won't be able to touch them. Of course, it required tremendous effort and a lot of stamina to maintain this state, and the disciples could feel their spiritual energy depleting at a rapid rate.

As for Yuan, since he was a peak Spirit Warrior, he had plenty of spiritual energy to spare, and compared to the other disciples, he only needed to expend some of his spiritual energy to block the poison since his spiritual energy was much more powerful.

"Brother Yuan, you don't even need to use any spiritual energy to defend against poison at this level," Xiao Hua's voice suddenly resounded in his head.

"Furthermore, with Brother Yuan's ability to resist poison, something that he'd obtained from consuming the Demonic Spider's Monster Core, the Weeping Serpent's poison won't have any effect on you."

'Really? Let me try it...'

Trusting Xiao Hua's words, Yuan stopped cultivating and covering his body with spiritual energy, allowing the purple smoke to engulf his body.

'Xiao Hua's right. I don't feel any different.' Yuan was pleasantly surprised by this.

However, when the sect elder saw this, she immediately retrieved a brown pill and tossed it at Yuan.

"Eat it quickly or you'll die!" Elder Tantai thought Yuan had already exhausted his cultivation and was exposed to the poison.

"Eh?" Yuan subconsciously caught the brown pill, but he didn't eat it and instead said to her, "But I'm fine."

"What?" Elder Tantai's eyes widened with surprise after hearing Yuan's word, and upon closer inspection, Yuan didn't appear to be struggling at all.

'What is going on?' she asked herself.

Yuan was clearly exposed to the Weeping Serpent's poison, but for some reason, he was completely fine.

'Does he have a unique physique that protects him from poison?' Elder Tantai could only think of this logical explanation to Yuan's situation. However, if that was the case, why didn't he do it early to save some spiritual energy?

Elder Tantai decided to not think too deeply about this as long as Yuan was fine.

"Keep the pill just in case you feel any symptoms. If you feel unpleasant or sick even the slightest at any moment, consume that pill immediately or you will really die," she then said to him.

"I understand." Yuan nodded his head and proceeded to sit there with a calm atmosphere around him.

"..."

Despite listening to their puzzling conversation, the other disciples did not stop focusing on protecting themselves, fearing that if they lose focus for even a second that they might fail the exam.

Fifteen minutes later, the incense stick only burned halfway to the end, and over half of the disciples there were already soaked in sweat, looking like they could barely hold on.

Elder Tantai took note of the disciples who she believes will fail soon and prepared the antidote in advance.

A minute later, the first disciple to exhaust his cultivation base before the entire incense stick burned, and Elder Tantai tossed the pill at him.

The disciple did not hesitate to consume the pill, as he could feel his skin burning the second the smoke touched his body.

After another couple of minutes later, over a dozen disciples swallowed the same pill, failing the examination.

The incense stick lasted for exactly thirty minutes, and at the end of the test, fifty-one disciples failed the examination.

"70 of you remaining, huh? Much better than I'd expected, to be honest." Elder Tantai nodded her head in approval.

"You have ten minutes to rest before we begin the next test." Elder Tantai said to them afterward.

The disciples immediately sat down to cultivate and restore their spiritual energy.

While the disciples rested, Elder Tantai prepared the next test by placing a Training Puppet in the middle of the field.

Ten minutes later, Elder Tantai clapped her hands and spoke loudly, "You are done resting! If you continue, I will immediately fail you! Gather in front of me!"

The disciples quickly stopped their cultivation and stood up after hearing Elder Tantai's words.

A few moments later, all of the disciples gathered in front of Elder Tantai.

"I will now explain the second test." Elder Tantai said as she pointed at the silver-colored training puppet that looked slightly different compared to the ones in the Practice Area.

"Some of you might have seen this before, but this is a special training puppet mostly used by Inner Court and Core disciples because they are more durable than the ones in the Outer Court, and they have a special feature that allows them to gauge how powerful their attacks are."

As her sentence ended, Elder Tantai turned around and punched the training puppet.

Boom!

The impact sounded very powerful, but the training puppet only moved back a couple of meters.

A few seconds later, the training puppet began changing colors from silver to a dark yellow color.

"The colors will determine how much damage it'd sustained. There are three colors— Green, yellow, and red. Green means nonlethal damage. Yellow is lethal. As for red, it means you can kill even a Spirit Warrior magical beast with that strike, and the darker the color the more damage they sustain. In order to pass this test, you must make the puppet turn yellow." Elder Tantai explained.

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Chapter 256 - Exploded Into Many Pieces

"Oh, one more thing. You are not allowed to use your own weapon in this test." Elder Tantai added, and she pointed to the weapon rack not far in the distance and continued, "Use one of those."

"Are there any questions?"

One of the disciples there raised his hand and said, "We can use any technique we want, right?"

Elder Tantai nodded, "That's right."

Sometime later, after the questions, Elder Tantai said, "If you wish to challenge the training puppet, step forward."

A few seconds after Elder Tantai's words, a disciple at the peak Spirit Apprentice stepped forward and spoke loudly, "I will go first!"

He then went to pick up a spear from the weapon rack before coming back and approaching the training puppet.

The disciple stood a few steps in front of the training puppet and took a moment to prepare himself.

After taking a long and deep breath, the disciple raised his spear.

Once the spear was raised perfectly parallel to the ground, the disciple held his breath for a second before thrusting it forward.

Boom!

The training puppet was sent flying backward, but it slowed down very quickly and stopped five meters away from its original spot.

The disciple waited for the evaluation nervously, and a few seconds later the training puppet turned from silver to green, then dark green, before finally settling at yellow.

"You passed." Elder Tantai said.

"Yes!" The disciple shouted in excitement before returning the spear in the weapons rack.

A few minutes later, another disciple stood before the training puppet that had returned to its original spot with a different weapon in his hand— a sword.

"Haaaa.... Ha!"

The disciple slashed the sword in his hand, creating a powerful strike that made the training puppet fall to its knees.

Once it stood up again, the colors began changing.

Light green... dark green... light yellow...

"You passed." Elder Tantai said once the color stopped at light yellow.

The next disciple went, but he didn't pick up a weapon and stood before the training puppet with his bare fists.

"Mountain Shattering Fist Strike!"

The disciple threw a punch with immense force at the training puppet, sending it flying many meters away.

After falling down a dozen meters away, the training puppet got back up and slowly walked back to its original spot while changing colors as it walked.

Dark green... light yellow... dark yellow...

"Not bad." Elder Tantai nodded her head when she saw this, and she continued, "You pass."

"Thank you, Elder." The disciple bowed to her before standing with the other two who had passed before him.

The disciples continued to challenge the training puppet one by one, and in less than an hour, over half of the disciples used their turn.

"Light yellow— pass."

"Light yellow— pass."

"Dark green— fail."

"Dark green— fail."

"Light Yellow— pass."

Out of the thirty-something disciples that challenged the training puppet, only two-thirds of them had managed to pass the test by scoring a yellow color. However, nobody there has managed to make the training puppet turn red.

A few more tries later, a disciple with a first-level Spirit Warrior cultivation base has finally managed to hit the training puppet hard enough for it to turn light red.

"Heavens! What a powerful martial skill! I could feel the impact even from here! I don't even dare to imagine what it must feel like to get struck by such a powerful blow!"

The disciples were shocked by this young man who was wielding a greatsword in his hands.

"I recognize that martial skill! It's the 'Relentless Force', an Earth-rank martial skill!"

"No wonder why it was so powerful! To think he'd trained an Earth-rank technique to such a high level! What astounding talents and display!"

Elder Tantai clapped afterward, and she spoke in a praising voice, "Great! It's been a while since a disciple has managed to hit a red color during the examination. In fact, the last time someone managed to hit red was almost a year ago."

"Thank you, Elder, for your praises!"

Sometime later, once everyone else went, it was only Yuan who hadn't gone.

"That's Disciple Yuan who defeated the Mad Tiger. What color do you think he'll achieve?" The disciples immediately started mumbling to each other while Yuan went to the weapons rack to pick his weapon.

"Who knows, really. During his match with the Mad Tiger, he didn't lift even a finger and used some mysterious technique to take down the Mad Tiger."

"I have a feeling he'll hit a dark yellow, maybe even light red."

"I think it'll only be light yellow."

A few moments later, Yuan returned to the training puppet with a sword in his hand, and the other disciples stopped talking to watch with intensive gazes.

'Hmm... What technique should I use?' Yuan thought to himself.

While the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike is his most powerful technique available, he didn't want to destroy this place. As for his next strongest sword technique, Demon Sealing Technique, it was out of the question since he has never used it before. Therefore, he could only use the Bloody Sword Strike, his most used technique.

After taking an offensive stance, Yuan took a deep breath.

Once he released his breath, the sword in his hand began glowing bright red, and Yuan swung the sword with all of his might.

Boom!

Yuan's aura exploded with a tyrannical feeling, and a red arc of light appeared in the air as the sword connected with the training puppet's neck.

Cling!

To Yuan's surprise, the blade to the sword in his hand exploded into many pieces after Yuan struck the training puppet.

However, that was not the only thing to break during his strike, as the training puppet's head was cleanly sliced off from its body like it had been executed.

"WHAT?!" Elder Tantai shouted in a shocked voice when she saw this, as this is her first time seeing someone destroy a training puppet in such a manner.

As for the other disciples, their eyes were wide as saucers with their jaws dropped to the ground, looking like they'd just witnessed something impossible.

Chapter 257 - Powerful Magical Beast

"What in the name of heavens just happened?! Am I imagining things or did he just decapitate the special training puppet that even Spirit Warriors cannot destroy?!"

One of the disciples there mumbled in a dazed voice as he stared at the silver head that had rolled a few meters away after being detached from its body.

Meanwhile, the training puppet that Yuan had decapitated continued to function, turning colors.

Light green, dark green, light yellow, dark yellow, light red, dark red... black!

To everybody's surprise, the special training puppet had suddenly turned black—a color they didn't know existed, much less seen before!

Yuan looked at the broken sword in his grasp with a dazed expression on his face. He didn't expect the sword to break so easily; it felt like he'd smashed a rock with an egg. However, to his surprise, he'd still managed to decapitate the training puppet.

Of course, it was the spiritual energy released from the sword that had sliced the training puppet's head cleanly off its body, as the sword was destroyed the moment it touched the puppet's tough body due to the immense force behind it.

Sometime later, once she snapped out of her daze, Elder Tantai approached the training puppet to examine its damage with a perplexed look on her face, seemingly trying to figure out what the heck just happened.

She then looked at Yuan's broken sword.

"I don't recognize the technique you'd just used. What rank is it?" she then asked him.

"Earth-rank," he calmly responded.

"..."

Elder Tantai questioned her own existence after learning that Yuan had managed to decapitate a special training puppet with an Earth-rank technique while she can't even damage it with a technique of the same rank and a cultivation base of 7th level Spirit Warrior.

"A-Anyway... you passed..." Elder Tantai said after a moment of silence.

Even if she can't comprehend what just happened, she couldn't deny what was right before her eyes.

Fortunately for her, Yuan was the last person to take the test, or she would've needed to find another special training puppet, which would have delayed the examination for at least two to three hours since nobody could've expected an Outer Court disciple destroying a special training puppet that even Core Disciples cannot destroy.

"As expected of the one who defeated the Mad Tiger without lifting a finger... If he'd lifted his finger, perhaps that match would've ended up as a deathmatch..."

The disciples there wholeheartedly believed that Wu Laohu had lucked out when Yuan decided to let him survive.

Sometime later, Elder Tantai gathered the disciples again and said, "There are twenty-four of you left, and we will be heading to the final test where

you must defeat a magical beast before you become an Inner Court disciple. If you have any questions, ask away."

One of the disciples immediately raised his hand and asked, "What kind of magical beasts will we be fighting?"

Elder Tantai then responded in a calm voice, "It's a powerful magical beast that is mostly found within the Jade Forest—the Jade Frog."

"The Jade Frog?!" The disciples expressed shock upon hearing this name.

Jade Frogs are incredibly hard to deal with since they have a large body and tough skin, and they like to jump around. A single mistake could lead to their bodies getting flattened.

Meanwhile, Yuan tilted his head after hearing this familiar name.

'Jade Frog? Isn't this the first monster that I have fought in this game? The one that nearly gave me a heart attack because I thought it'd turned Xiao Hua's body into meat paste?' Yuan remembered his encounter with the Jade Frog as though it was just yesterday, as that was his first combat experience in this world.

"Who would like to go first?" Elder Tantai asked the disciples after answering all of their questions.

"I'd like to go first." An eager voice immediately responded.

The disciples turned to look at the voice, and to their surprise, Yuan had volunteered to go first.

"S-Sure, go ahead." Elder Tantai said, and she continued, "One of the gates at the end will open once the test begins, and you will have fifteen minutes to defeat the Jade Frog or it's an automatic loss. And just like the previous test, you can only use the equipment provided to you."

Yuan nodded his head before heading to the weapons rack to pick up another weapon.

This time, he chose a dagger, surprising the Elder Tantai and the other disciples with his choice.

"Why's he using the dagger? I thought for sure he was going to use the sword again!"

"Is he trying to show off or something? This test is entirely different compared to the previous two tests. You need a lot of experience and knowledge to fight a magical beast, especially the Jade Frog that's well known for killing inexperienced Cultivators who are not used to their attack patterns."

"Who knows. He's done nothing but surprise since the beginning. Maybe he'll do the same for this time as well."

Sometime later, once Yuan was standing in the middle of the field with the other disciples standing all the way in the back, Elder Tantai shouted, "Release the magical beast!"

The metal gates immediately opened, and the ground began shaking as a Jade Frog made its appearance by hopping out of the entrance.

The disciples swallowed nervously when they saw the Jade Frog and its intimidating appearance.

Meanwhile, Yuan stared at the round magical beast with a nostalgic feeling.

BOOM!

The Jade Frog stopped moving after it landed a few meters away from Yuan, and it proceeded to stare at Yuan and the others there as though it was analyzing them and their situation.

In this stillness and silence, a movement was suddenly made, but it was not by the Jade Frog.

Instead, it was Yuan who moved first, as he'd suddenly tossed his dagger into the air.

A vicious light flickered in his eyes, and right as the dagger in the air reached its highest point and prepared to fall down, it suddenly stopped moving and hovered in the air for a split second before shooting itself at the Jade Frog like a shooting star.

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Chapter 258 - Becoming An Inner Court Disciple

The moment it saw the dagger trembling in the air, the Jade Frog sensed imminent danger, causing its body to instinctively jump up to avoid it.

Whoosh!

The Flying Dagger barely missed the Jade Frog. However, before the Jade Frog could even land, the Flying Dagger suddenly did a sharp turn and flew at it again like there was a string attached to the Jade Frog.

Whoosh!

A gaping hole appeared before the Jade Frog's forehead a split second later, instantly killing it.

Thud!

The ground shook when the large and heavy Jade Frog's lifeless body fell down from the sky, shocking the spectators.

Once the place was still, Yuan turned around and walked back to be with the rest of the disciples without even turning around or checking whether the Jade Frog was truly dead or not.

"I have defeated the Jade Frog. Am I an Inner Court disciple now?" Yuan asked Elder Tantai who stood there with a gawking look on her face.

After a long moment of silence, Elder Tantai nodded her head in a stiff movement before speaking, "Y-Yes... Congratulations on becoming an Inner

Court disciple, Disciple Yuan... here's your badge. Take this to the distribution center to get your Inner Court disciple badge and robes..."

Yuan accepted the badge with humbleness before walking out of the examination hall in a casual manner, almost like he was taking a stroll in a park.

The other disciples there watched as Yuan's back disappeared from their sights.

"Just where on earth did this Disciple Yuan come from and how come I have never heard of him until recently? There's no way such a genius would be a nobody!" Elder Tantai mumbled to herself in a dazed voice.

Sometime later, once the Jade Frog's corpse was taken away, Elder Tantai resumed the examination.

Meanwhile, Yuan went to the distribution hall and handed the elder at the front desk the badge he'd just obtained from Elder Tantai.

"So you just passed the Inner Court Disciple Examination, huh? Congratulations." The sect elder there treated him with respect, taking Yuan by surprise.

After all, he's been treated like an insect most of the time by the sect elders in this sect—at least that's what it feels like, and it was a refreshing feeling to be respected by a sect elder.

"Can I have your old identification badge?" The sect elder then asked him.

Yuan nodded and handed him the bronze identification badge.

"I'll be right back." The sect elder went to the back of the room for a few minutes before returning.

"Here you go. I have updated your identification badge. As for your living quarters, you can choose to stay in your current place or be assigned a new living quarter in the Inner Court."

Yuan immediately responded without any hesitation, "I will remain in my current residence."

The sect elder was slightly surprised by Yuan's decision. After all, the living quarters within the Inner Court are more spacious and luxurious overall, and you only have one roommate compared to the 5 roommates in the Outer Court. Any logical being would choose to live in the Inner Court.

'Perhaps he doesn't want to leave his friends?' The sect elder could only think of one reason for Yuan's decision.

"If that's your decision, then I won't say anything. However, if you wish to move to the Inner Court for whatever reason, you can come back here and we'll arrange something for you," said the sect elder a moment later.

And he continued, "Now about your new uniforms... Which color do you want? Blue or green?"

"Does it matter which one I choose?" Yuan asked.

"No, it doesn't matter. It's just a preference thing."

"Then I'll choose blue."

"Very well. I'll be right back again."

The sect elder went to the back for a second time before returning a few minutes later with three sets of blue uniforms.

"Here you go. If the sizes don't fit, you may return to exchange them."

"Thank you, Senior." Yuan accepted the uniforms.

"One more thing before you leave. There'll be a lecture tomorrow that'll introduce you to life as an Inner Court disciple. If you can, please attend it. It'll be at the Education Peak in building #111."

"I understand. I'll try to attend it." Yuan nodded.

Sometime later, Yuan left the distribution hall and returned to his own living quarters.

"Hm?"

Min Li, who was just about to leave her house, noticed Yuan's approaching figure and the blue robes he was carrying.

"D-Disciple Yuan! Those uniforms— You're an Inner Court disciple now?!" Min Li exclaimed in a shocked voice.

Yuan nodded and said, "Yes, I just took the examination today and became an Inner Court disciple."

Min Li's jaw dropped to the ground.

"W-Why didn't you tell me?! I would've done the examination with you!" Min Li asked him.

"That... never crossed my mind... I didn't know you wanted to take the examination as well," Yuan said in an apologetic voice.

"I-I am not blaming you or anything..." Min Li quickly said.

"Anyways, now that you're an Inner Court disciple, will you be moving out?" Min Li then asked him.

"No, I will be staying here," Yuan responded.

"Really?" A pleasantly surprised expression on Min Li's face.

"Why?" she couldn't help but ask him, hoping that he would say something romantic like 'because of you' or something along that line.

But alas, Yuan said, "There's really no reason for me to move out of such a nice house."

"Eh? But you will have to walk to the Inner Court every time you need something from there, which will take up a lot of time."

"It's okay. I like to be active, anyways."

"I-Is that so..." Min Li mumbled.

Normally, Cultivators want to spend as much time as they could on cultivation whilst saving time for everything else so they can have more time for cultivation. However, for geniuses like Yuan, minor things like that don't really matter, as it won't affect their extreme cultivation speed much if any at all.

Sometime later, Min Li left the place to go to the practice area.

'The next Inner Court Disciple Examination is in three months... haaa...'
Min Li sighed inwardly as she left the place.

Meanwhile, Yuan went back to his own room.

"Congratulations on becoming an Inner Court disciple, Brother Yuan." Xiao Hua said to him.

"Thank you, Xiao Hua," Yuan said to her.

A few moments later, Yuan sat down and began training his Divine Sense.

Once the sky began turning dark, Yuan logged off the game and waited for Meixiu to return home.

"I'm back, Yuan," Meixiu said to him after closing the door.

"Welcome back, Meixiu."

"I'll prepare dinner right now."

After putting down her stuff from school and changing her clothes, Meixiu went to cook dinner.

Once that was done, Meixiu went to feed Yuan.

"Yuan, you need to be careful when you're playing the game," Meixiu suddenly warned him.

"Huh? Why would you say that?" Yuan asked.

"The Young Lady told me to warn you because there will be a lot of players trying to get into the Dragon Essence Temple to meet you."

"Really? I should start wearing my mask even in the sect then..." Yuan mumbled.

"The Young Lady also told me to warn you to stay away from people who try to ask you personal questions even if they might be an NPC because players can disguise themselves as NPCs and you won't know it."

"I understand. I'll be careful," Yuan said.

"By the way, how is Yu Rou doing at school? I hope she's doing fine after what happened recently."

"The Young Lady is doing much better. Furthermore, she can always meet you in Cultivation Online— at least that's what she keeps telling herself."

"I see... I plan on leaving the Dragon Essence Temple to spend more time with Yu Rou in a week or so anyway. I cannot leave until I participate in the Mystic Realm, since I promised the Sect Master and others that I'd help them."

"The Mystic Realm?" Meixiu raised her eyebrows.

Sometime later, after she finished feeding Yuan dinner, Meixiu said, "I'll let you rest for a bit before I wash your body, Yuan."

"Okay."

Meixiu went to clean the dishes afterward.

Half an hour later, Meixiu returned to the room with his wheelchair.

After picking Yuan up from the bed and placing him in the chair, Meixiu pushed him to the bathroom, where she helped him undress.

And since she didn't want to get her clothes wet while washing Yuan, Meixiu decided to also take her clothes off and went into the bathroom with him naked.

Once they were inside the bathroom, Meixiu squeezed some body wash onto her palms before she rubbed it all over Yuan's body.

Once Yuan's body was covered in body wash, Meixiu used a soft scrubber and began scrubbing his body.

'This is my first time washing him...' Meixiu thought to herself as she cleaned whatever she could.

A few moments later, Meixiu reached his lower area, and her eyes subconsciously moved to look at the cute thing between Yuan's legs.

Almost like she was mesmerized or something, Meixiu couldn't find the strength to look away, and she proceeded to stare at it with a dazed look on her face.

Meixiu finally snapped out of her daze a few moments later, and she proceeded to wash Yuan's legs, ignoring the thing in the middle for now.

'What is this feeling?' Meixiu swallowed nervously when she noticed her heart beating faster than usual, feeling as though the temperature in the room had suddenly increased.

Chapter 259 - An Unexpected Phenomenon

"I know I said this before, but I really appreciate you doing this for me, Meixiu." Yuan suddenly said to her while she scrubbed his legs.

"D-Don't worry about it... You have also helped me out a lot when I didn't know any better as a child." Meixiu responded in a low voice.

When she was a young child who was still in training to be the perfect servant, she would often make mistakes and get scolded by her mother. When that happens, Meixiu would cry like any other brat and seek Yuan for comfort.

"I was originally trained to serve you, Yuan, but after what happened to you, they decided to assign me to the Young Lady instead..." Meixiu suddenly said.

"At one point, I was even..."

Meixiu suddenly stopped midway through her sentence.

"Meixiu?"

"Never mind that... I was just talking to myself," Meixiu mumbled a moment later.

After cleaning Yuan's legs, there was only one place that still needed to be cleaned—the area between his legs.

Meixiu swallowed nervously at the thought of touching this cute snake, almost like she feared that it might bite her if she approached it.

However, as much as she wanted to leave that place alone, she was trained to do her job properly; it was inexcusable for her to half-ass a job or leave her job unfinished.

Therefore, she could only swallow her nervousness and reach for the soft thing between Yuan's legs and began cleaning it with her hands, as it was very difficult to clean every nook and cranny with the sponge.

A chill went up Yuan's spine when Meixiu began cleaning his precious thing. Perhaps it was due to his Spirit Warrior cultivation base, but the sensation of his own body has significantly improved since then, allowing him to feel a lot more. He'd already noticed this when Meixiu began washing his body, but it wasn't as apparent as currently for some reason, almost like the area between his legs was much more sensitive than other areas on his body.

And then an unexpected phenomenon happened.

"This is..." Meixiu's eyes widened with shock when the small snake suddenly started growing larger and larger.

Since this is her first time washing Yuan, it is only obvious that she has no prior knowledge, so she didn't know if Yuan's sprout was normal in such situations.

Of course, Yuan was oblivious to this natural reaction on his body.

Meixiu didn't know whether she should continue or stop at this point, but she eventually convinced herself to continue.

Thus, Meixiu began washing Yuan again but with a slight difference— she was rushing it, something she had never done before.

A few seconds later, Meixiu finally stopped washing him and began rinsing the soap off his body with the showerhead.

"I am finished..." Meixiu spoke in a tiny voice afterward, her face flushed with redness.

"Thank you, Meixiu." Yuan said to her in a calm voice, completely oblivious to the blushing expression on Meixiu's face at this moment.

Sometime later, Meixiu laid a large dry towel on Yuan's bed before placing Yuan on this blanket and drying his body off with another towel.

'It's back to normal again...' Meixiu thought to herself as she dried his body.

After drying Yuan's body, Meixiu helped Yuan put his clothes on.

"I am done here, Yuan. I am going to clean myself now..." Meixiu said, still completely naked at this point.

"Okay. You can go to sleep afterward."

"Goodnight, Yuan."

"Goodnight."

Meixiu went to the bathroom to wash herself shortly after, and Yuan began cultivating.

'What was that warm sensation just now?' Yuan wondered to himself before he started his cultivation.

Meanwhile, Meixiu spent longer than usual in the bathroom. Once she was finally out again, she went straight to her room and sat on her bed with a dazed look on her face for many minutes before she decided to put on the console and enter Cultivation Online to see whether Yuan's friend was there.

After spending half an hour of waiting with no results, Meixiu logged off the game to sleep.

That night, Meixiu had a weird dream where she was surrounded by mushrooms and snakes.

The following morning, after feeding Yuan breakfast, Meixiu went to school.

"You look tired, Meixiu. Did you not get enough sleep last night? This is my first time seeing you like this." Yu Rou said to Meixiu inside the car when she noticed Meixiu's dazed look.

"N-No... I am fine, Young Lady." Meixiu responded with a slight delay.

"I see... If you need to rest, just let me know and I'll give the teachers an excuse so you can rest for the day."

"Thank you, Young Lady, but I am fine."

"How's Brother Tian?" Yu Rou then asked.

"The Young Master is doing great, and as usual, he's eating three bowls of soup with ease," she responded.

"I see... By the way, this reminds me, you were supposed to be Brother Tian's servant at one point, right? I remember your mother saying something like that to me before." Yu Rou suddenly asked.

"T-That's right... I was trained to support the Young Master and satisfy his every need." Meixiu nodded.

Yu Rou's eyes widened, and she mumbled in a slightly surprised voice, "That sounds like they trained you to become his wife or something."

"..."

Meixiu remained silent regarding Yu Rou's statement, yet a weird glint flickered in her eyes.

"Do you regret it?" Yu Rou continued to ask. "Not being able to work for Brother Tian despite training for it, I mean."

"While it did feel bitter at first since it felt like all of the training I did was for nothing, I was able to assist the Young Lady because of the skills I had

learned with that training, so I don't have any regrets," Meixiu answered after a moment of silence.

"But you're taking care of Brother Tian now, just like you were trained. It feels like fate," Yu Rou chuckled at her own statement.

Sometime later, they arrived at school and began their classes.

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Chapter 260 - You Tricked Me!

While Meixiu went to school with Yu Rou, Yuan continued to train his Divine Sense in Cultivation Online.

Meanwhile, at the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower, Long Yijun and the other Sect Masters stared in shock as the 99th floor emitted a golden light.

"H-He really did it! He's managed to reach the 100th floor!"

The disciples there mumbled to each other with surprise.

"Who's currently inside? I just arrived."

"Shui Zi, the number one genius of the Grand Saber Palace!"

"Shui Zi, huh? I heard he managed to reach Spirit Warrior at the young age of 18 and peak of Spirit Warrior at 27 years old. He's definitely up there even for a genius."

Meanwhile, the Sect Masters laughed out loud, "Hahaha! Looks like this will be the last person to challenge this tower even though we still have 2 more people!"

"I was getting worried for a second, but it's relieving to see someone finally reach the final floor!"

Despite most of their disciples challenging the tower, most of them had stopped around the 90th floor, and only Shui Zi managed to reach the 100th floor.

However, Long Yijun did not show any signs of worry, and he merely stared at the tower with a calm look on his face.

"What do you think about this, Elder Xuan? Do you think he'll beat the 100th floor?" Elder Bai suddenly asked him.

"I want to say it's impossible, but we have been taught again and again that there's no such thing as 'impossible' by 'him'. Though, it is still unlikely that he would be able to pass that floor." Elder Xuan said with a bittersweet smile on his face.

Meanwhile, inside the tower, a handsome young man with a fierce expression on his face slowly climbed the stairs to the 100th floor after spending 15 minutes recovering his strength.

"Already the last floor? I will give this place some credit since it was not easy climbing to this level, but alas, it looks like I am fated to defeat this tower." Shui Zi said with a confident smile on his face.

A few moments later, Shui Zi stepped onto the 100th floor and was greeted by the new scenery.

"What a vast place... Am I still inside the tower? Or is this merely an illusion?" Shui Zi mumbled in a dazed voice.

"Anyways, where are the monsters? Hurry up and come out so I can beat this boring tower already." Shui Zi shouted out loud in an arrogant voice.

"Hoh? A boring tower, huh?"

The space before Shui Zi suddenly twisted, and a gaping hole appeared in the space a moment later.

Then, Shui Zi watched with wide eyes as a massive golden dragon appeared from within the black hole.

Once it appeared, the Great One gazed upon Shui Zi as though he was an ant and spoke in a calm voice, "While I will give you credit for making it

here, nor did I expect someone else to come here so soon after the last one, but you don't have what it takes to clear the 100th floor."

"..."

Shui Zi did not respond to the Great One, mostly because he was frozen stiff from shock and fear.

"Hmph. What a boring one." The Great One shook its head when it saw the state Shui Zi was in.

"Anyways, since you want to get this over with, allow me to tell you the challenge for this floor."

BOOM!

An intense aura suddenly exploded from the Great One's large body, causing the entire world to shake.

"If you want to defeat the 100th floor, you must defeat me!" The Great One's voice echoed in Shui Zi's ears.

"I-Impossible! You're asking for the impossible! This isn't fair! How the fuck am I supposed to defeat a dragon?!" Shui Zi was snapped out of his daze by the Great One's aura that activated his instincts and desire to run.

"Hahaha!"

The Great One suddenly laughed before speaking, "Impossible? If it was impossible, how did the person who came before you pass the floor and defeat the tower?"

"Are you telling me that this person defeated you?!" Shui Zi exclaimed.

"No, we didn't fight, and I had another challenge for him."

"What?! That's even more unfair! Why are you giving me a different challenge, then?!"

A mysterious smile appeared on the Great One's face, and it spoke in a calm voice, "If you'd like, I can let you take that challenge instead."

"Really?"

A hopeful look appeared on Shui Zi's face after hearing this and he immediately nodded his head, "Yes! I want to take that challenge!"

"Very well..."

The Great One said.

A few moments later, the ground suddenly began rumbling, startling Shui Zi.

'What the heck is this shaking?' he wondered to himself.

The Great One spoke as a black line appeared on the horizon.

"For this challenge, you must defeat 100,000 peak Spirit Warrior magical beasts. You will have unlimited time to do so and 24 hours of rest time, and you may pause this challenge whenever you wish. However, once your 24 hours run out, you will have to fight until your last breath."

Shui Zi's eyes widened with shock after hearing this.

"You want me to fight against 100,000 Spirit Warrior magical beasts?! This is even more impossible than fighting you! You tricked me! There's no way anyone could possibly pass this trial even if they're given a week to rest!" Shui Zi pointed at the Great One with trembling hands.

"Why would I trick you? The last person cleared this challenge with no problem at all." The Great One shook its head.

"Then tell me who defeated this challenge?! I'll believe you then!"

However, the Great One shook its head and said, "That person's name is too great for someone like you. If you do not accept the challenge, then you will automatically forfeit."

Shui Zi gritted his teeth in anger, and he turned to look at the sea of magical beasts that were swarming towards him at this moment, his back soaked in cold sweats.

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Chapter 261 - Impossible To Beat

Shui Zi watched as the sea of magical beasts quickly closed their distance, and once they were only half a mile away, Shui Zi could no longer keep calm and shouted, "I give up! I give up! Get me out of here!"

The Great One coldly snorted after seeing Shui Zi surrender the challenge, "Not even going to attempt the challenge? You're a much bigger coward than I'd anticipated. Get lost. You do not qualify to even be in my presence!"

The Great One's eyes flickered with a golden light, and before Shui Zi realized it, he was back on the first floor of the tower.

Meanwhile, outside the tower, Long Yijun and the other Sect Masters just witnessed the lights on all 99 floors turn off, signaling Shui Zi's failure.

"What?!"

The Sect Masters there were speechless by this, as they'd truly expedited Shui Zi to defeat the tower.

A few moments later, Shui Zi left the tower with a dazed look on his face, looking empty, almost like he was dead inside.

"Shui Zi! What happened in there?! You were so close!" His Sect Master quickly approached him.

"I... I... can't do it. No human being can pass the 100th floor. It's impossible." Shui Zi responded in a voice of disbelief.

The Sect Masters there immediately frowned, and one of them asked, "What do you mean by that? What was on the 100th floor?"

"It... It was a dragon— a real dragon. I had to defeat a dragon." Shui Zi spoke, and his body trembled upon recalling the Great One's intimidating aura.

"What! A dragon?! Don't tell me you had to fight this dragon!" The Sect Masters there were shocked.

Even Long Yijun and the high-ranking sect elders were surprised by this since they didn't hear anything about a dragon from Yuan!

Shui Zi nodded and said, "It was a golden dragon, and it had the cultivation of a Spirit Master."

After taking a deep breath, he continued, "However, that's not even the worst part, since there was another challenge on the 100th floor, which involves defeating 100,000 Spirit Warrior magical beasts with only 24 hours to rest."

"100,000 Spirit Warrior magical beasts?! How is that even possible?!" The Sect Masters there repeated in a shocked voice, their expressions filled with disbelief. Even if they challenged this tower themselves, they would not dare to claim that they can defeat 100,000 magical beasts.

Shui Zi nodded again and said, "Furthermore, the dragon claimed that someone had managed to clear that challenge by defeating all 100,000 magical beasts."

'That's the challenge Disciple Yuan told us about...' Elder Xuan thought to himself after hearing Shui Zi's words.

At that moment, the Sect Masters there turned to look at Long Yijun who was casually sitting there with a smug look on his face.

"What are you looking at? You still have two more disciples. Hurry up, the Mystic Realm is coming up and I need to finish preparing for that." Long Yijun said to them.

However, the Sect Masters did not send another disciple inside the tower, and they remained standing there while staring at Long Yijun with deep frowns on their faces.

If what Shui Zi said was true— that they had to either defeat a Spirit Master dragon or fight 100,000 Spirit Warrior magical beasts, there was simply no way the remaining two disciples would be able to defeat this tower.

In other words, they are destined to lose their bet!

"Sect Master Long, you tricked us! You knew it was impossible to beat this tower, so you made the bet with the Dragon Slaying Saber as bait!"

One of the Sect Masters suddenly pointed at Long Yijun and blamed him for tricking them.

However, Long Yijun remained calm and said, "No shit, you idiot. Why else would I dare to gamble the Dragon Slaying Saber? With that being said, you are wrong about one thing— that the tower is impossible to defeat. If it's really impossible, how did my disciple defeat it?"

"Bullshit! I bet your disciple had an entirely different challenge and the tower is merely screwing with us because we're not disciples of this sect! Or you manipulated the tower to give us an impossible challenge!" The Sect Masters said.

Long Yijun shook his head and said, "As if I have the power to manipulate the tower. In the history of the sect, nobody— and I mean not a single person before 'that' disciple had managed to clear all 100 floors, and even the Founder was defeated on the 100th floor!"

The Sect Masters' faces dropped after hearing such words. Not even their Ancestor who was known as the number one genius during his era could beat the 100th floor? Then what kind of monster does it take to defeat the tower? Just who is this disciple the Dragon Essence Temple is trying so hard to hide?

"I know what you're thinking, but I won't say anything. If you wish to meet this disciple, you'll see him at the Mystic Realm." Long Yijun laughed out loud.

"Che!"

The Sect Masters there snickered coldly.

"Anyways, are you going to continue or not? If not, you can forfeit the bet and your treasures as well." Long Yijun held his hand out in a lazy manner.

The Sect Masters gritted their teeth in frustration.

Even though they knew it was impossible for the remaining disciples to defeat the tower, they couldn't just hand their treasures to Long Yijun without even trying, as that would simply make things even more embarrassing for them!

"I will challenge the tower!" One of the remaining two disciples suddenly stepped forward and said.

"Chances are I will not be able to defeat the dragon or 100,000 magical beasts, but I will definitely try!"

The disciple's Sect Master nodded and said, "Well said! We have not lost just yet!"

Thus, the next disciple went inside the tower and began climbing it.

'Go ahead, keep struggling. The results will remain the same, anyways.'
Long Yijun laughed inwardly at their futile efforts.

Chapter 262 - Abnormal Amount Of Visitors

Sometime after the next challenger went inside the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower, Long Yijun mumbled to Elder Xuan who was sitting right beside him, "He should be an Inner Court disciple by now. Go find him and let him enter the Dragon's Peak alongside Fei Yuyan."

Elder Xuan nodded, "I understand."

When the other Sect Masters noticed Elder Xuan leaving the scene, they asked, "Where's he going?"

"Elder Xuan does not want to waste any more of his time here since he already knows the outcome. Therefore, he's leaving to work." Long Yijun responded in a nonchalant voice.

"Y-You little—!"

The Sect Masters gritted their teeth at Long Yijun's obvious provocation. However, they didn't dare to claim that they will definitely win this bet, especially not after what they learned about the 100th floor.

Even for a Spirit Master like them, it would be impossible to defeat 100,000 magical beasts even if they were given a month, much less 24 hours of rest time, and they cannot fathom the talent and strength that is required to pass this tower.

If what the dragon on the 100th floor told Shui Zi was true— that someone had managed to defeat 100,000 magical beasts and clear the tower, then the

cultivation world is about to experience a turmoil it hasn't felt in countless years.

"Hey, what are you guys thinking?" One of the Sect Master there suddenly whispered to the other three.

"Isn't it obvious?! I'm thinking about how we can get ourselves out of this shithole! It's obvious that we won't win this bet. However, we'll be handing 4 Divine-grade treasures to the Dragon Essence Temple if we lose!"

"Is there anything we can really do at this point? We've sworn a blood oath! Unless you want to invoke a Heavenly Tribulation and curse your future generations, we cannot break the blood oath!"

"Fuck! We were blinded by the Dragon Slaying Saber! That bastard really got us good this time!"

"Even though we cannot do anything about the blood oath, we can still try to work something out with him after we give him our treasures. I highly doubt the Dragon Essence Temple wants to offend four sects at once!"

"Right! We can simply buy our Divine-grade treasures back, or we can offer something else in return for them!"

"Let's try to figure this out before our last disciple challenges the tower!"

Long Yijun noticed the other Sect Masters whispering to each other, and he could already imagine what they were talking about. However, it didn't matter to him, as the Dragon Essence Temple would benefit from this bet no matter what they did at this point, and he continued to watch the tower light up with golden lights.

Meanwhile, Elder Xuan went to Yuan's living quarters and knocked on the doors.

A few moments later, Yuan opened the door and greeted him, "Hello, Senior Xuan."

"Let's talk inside." Elder Xuan said.

Yuan nodded and closed the door after he entered.

Once they were seated, Elder Xuan began to speak, "First and foremost, allow me to congratulate you on becoming an Inner Court disciple."

"Thank you, the examination was pretty fun," Yuan said with a smile.

"Fun..."

A bittersweet smile appeared on Elder Xuan's face. In this entire sect, Yuan is probably the only disciple who would have fun during such an important examination.

"Anyway, I'm here to talk about the Dragon's Peak. The Sect Master wants you and Fei Yuyan to enter before the Mystic Realm that is only a week away. Are you available now? I can take you there right now."

Yuan nodded and said, "Yes, I am free. I was just training my Divine Sense."

"Training Divine Sense at your cultivation level, huh? I didn't start training my Divine Sense until I was a Spirit Master. Unfortunately, the Dragon Essence Temple doesn't have any Soul Techniques to assist you in that matter." Elder Xuan said.

"It's fine."

"Okay, then follow me. Let's go pick up Disciple Fei before we head to Dragon's Peak."

Just as Elder Xuan turned to walk towards the door, Yuan suddenly said, "Please wait a moment. Senior Xuan."

"Hmm?" Elder Xuan turned around and watched as Yuan retrieved a black jade mask before putting it on his face.

Elder Xuan raised his eyebrows after seeing this.

"Is it fine if I go outside with my mask? There are a lot of people looking for me, and I don't want them to recognize me." Yuan said.

Elder Xuan became even more puzzled after hearing his words, and he asked, "Are there disciples bothering you right now? I will immediately deal with them if that's the case—"

"No, it has nothing to do with the disciples, nor am I being bothered right now. However, there are people out there looking for me, and I have been told that they will be trying to enter the sect just to look for me because of my appearance at the zither competition."

"Now that you mention it, there has been an irregular amount of people trying to enter the sect as of lately, and most of them are rogue cultivators. Are they perhaps the people you're referring to?" Elder Xuan asked him.

Ever since the zither competition, a lot of people have been visiting the Dragon Essence Temple with some people even trying to sneak inside. However, none of the elders or Long Yijun found that weird, as it was normal for people to flock to the Dragon Essence Temple after what happened at the zither competition, and this is usually what happens after a competition or tournament.

Though, the number of people visiting the sect as of recent is through the roof and unlike anything the sect has experienced before, and most of them were rogue cultivators without any backgrounds.

"If these people are here because of you, then we need to tighten up the security around the sect..." Elder Xuan mumbled with a perplexed look on his face.

Sometime later, he said, "I'll speak with the Sect Master afterward. For now, let's get you and Disciple Fei to the Dragon's Peak so you can strengthen yourselves as much as possible before the Mystic Realm."

Chapter 263 - Dragons Peak

Chapter 263 - Dragon's Peak

After leaving the house, Elder Xuan led Yuan to the Inner Court to look for Fei Yuyan.

The appearance of Elder Xuan in the Outer Court surprised everyone and attracted countless gazes from the disciples around them, and they all bowed to him the moment they noticed him.

As a high-ranking sect elder, they are revered as much as the Sect Master himself, and they usually don't appear in public, much less the Outer Court, so for Elder Xuan, one of the most renowned high-ranking sect elder to appear in the Outer Court was very shocking, to say the least.

"Who's that Inner Court disciple following him? He's even wearing a mask..."

"Why is he wearing a mask? What's he trying to hide? His ugly face?"

"Who knows."

Sometime later, Elder Xuan and Yuan arrived at Fei Yuyan's living quarters and knocked on the doors.

After waiting for a few moments with no response, Elder Xuan knocked on the door again.

However, nobody answered the door.

"How odd..." Elder Xuan retrieved his jade slip and looked at it before continuing, "Disciple Fei hasn't signed out of the logbook so she should still be within the sect. Maybe she went to the Dragon Pavilion?"

"Do you have any idea where she went?" Elder Xuan decided to ask Yuan.

Yuan shook his head and said, "I tried to visit her a few days ago as well, but she wasn't here either."

"Let's go to Elder Shan's living quarters and see if Disciple Fei is there or if she knows Disciple Fei's location." Elder Xuan suggested.

Yuan nodded his head, and they proceeded to head to the Blossom Peak to see Elder Shan.

Sometime later, they knocked on Elder Shan's door.

"Who is it?" Elder Shan appeared before them a few moments later.

"Elder Xuan and... Disciple Yuan?" It took a few seconds for Elder Shan to recognize Yuan's black jade mask, and when she realized that it was Yuan, she subconsciously took a step back and covered her head with her hands.

"Elder Shan? What are you doing?" Elder Xuan raised his eyebrows when he saw her puzzling actions.

"A-Ahem! Nothing." Elder Shan cleared her throat before continuing, "Anyway, what are you doing here? And why are you hiding your face, Disciple Yuan?"

"It's a complicated situation for him, we'll discuss it later. As for now, we're looking for Disciple Fei so we can head to the Dragon's Peak. She wasn't at her house, so we figured to come here." Elder Xuan said.

"Oh, Fei Yuyan? She's currently in closed cultivation in the Immortal Caves." Elder Shan said.

"Immortal Caves? What's that?" Yuan immediately asked, his interest piqued.

"The Immortal Caves are located at Cloud Peak, where the spiritual energy is incredibly thick and abundant, only second to Dragon's Peak in the entire sect. Core Disciples usually spend the most time cultivating there, especially if there's nothing else to do outside. And since the Mystic Realm

is getting close, everybody wants to improve their cultivation as fast as possible to be eligible for the Mystic Realm."

"One must be eligible to participate in the Mystic Realm? How do you pick who gets to participate?" Yuan asked them.

"Well, the Mystic Realm is a mysterious place where one's overall strength and cultivation doesn't matter at all. Instead, one's talent reigns supreme. Everyone who enters the Mystic Realm will have their entire cultivation base wiped, but you'll regain your cultivation once you come back out." Elder Xuan explained to him.

And he continued, "Therefore, we pick the participants depending on their growth and improvements over a certain time. So far, you're the only disciple who is certain to participate in the Mystic Realm. As for the other two disciples... We'll figure it out by the end of the week.":

"Wow... A mystic place, indeed." Yuan's anticipation for this place grew slightly more.

"Anyway, since Disciple Fei isn't here and we can't just disturb her cultivation, I guess you'll have to go to Dragon's Peak by yourself for now, Disciple Yuan." Elder Xuan said to him.

"Okay." Yuan nodded.

"Thank you, Elder Shan. We'll see you later."

"Oh, right. Before I leave..." Yuan suddenly reached into his spatial ring and retrieved a cultivation technique.

"Can you give this to Disciple Fei when she comes out of cultivation?"

"This is...?" Elder Shan accepted the technique with a nonchalant look on her face.

However, when she realized what she was holding, her eyes widened with surprise, "The Divine-rank cultivation technique you'd obtained from the zither competition? You're already done with it?"

Yuan nodded, "Yes, I learned it quicker than I'd expected so I don't need it anymore. Please give it to Disciple Fei."

Elder Shan and Elder Xuan's jaws dropped after hearing his words. He'd managed to learn a Divine-rank technique in just a few days? As expected, his comprehension abilities are beyond their understanding.

"I understand... I will give this technique to Fei Yuyan when I see her." Elder Shan nodded her head.

"Thank you, Senior Shan!" Yuan said to her.

Elder Xuan and Yuan left the place shortly later, heading to Dragon's Peak that was almost two hours away.

"So this is the Dragon's Peak? It's... so empty..." Yuan stared at the spacious land before them with raised eyebrows.

"Well, the Founder was a simple man who loved to feel free, so he didn't have much if anything in his area," said Elder Xuan.

"I see... but the spiritual energy in this area... it's really abundant. I can feel my cultivation base slightly growing just from breathing in this place." Yuan mumbled.

"Rumors say this is caused by a treasure that the Founder had hidden in this place before his disappearance since this place was not like this in the beginning, and it only became like this after the Founder's disappearance." Elder Xuan said.

And he continued, "However, despite all of our efforts throughout the years, nobody has found the supposed treasure to this day, and it's been tens of thousands of years."

"I see..." Yuan mumbled with a pondering look on his face.

Chapter 264 - Where Is The Treasure?

"Anyway, you can stay here for as long as you like until the Mystic Realm begins. Although it might be a long shot, try to breakthrough to the Spirit Master realm before then. While your cultivation base may not matter in the Mystic Realm, it'll definitely shock a lot of people and affect their minds and performance." Elder Xuan said to him.

"If you need anything from me, just contact me using the communication jade slip. I'll be at the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower with the Sect Master and the others."

Yuan nodded, and he suddenly asked, "How are the guests doing? Did they manage to clear the tower yet?"

Elder Xuan shook his head and spoke with a smile on his face, "No, but one of them managed to reach the 100th floor. You didn't tell me about the dragon."

"Oh... I forgot... I'm sorry." Yuan said.

"Hahaha... Don't worry about it. It was a pleasant surprise. We won't blame you for it." Elder Xuan laughed out loud.

Sometime later, Elder Xuan left the place, leaving Yuan alone at Dragon's Peak.

"What am I supposed to do here? Just sit down and cultivate?" Yuan mumbled to himself since Elder Xuan didn't exactly give him any instructions.

"By the way, Xiao Hua, can you see the treasure in this place with your Divine Sense? I couldn't sense anything." Yuan suddenly asked her.

"No, Xiao Hua cannot sense anything either. The people in this place should've already swept this entire place with their Divine Sense, anyway, so either there's no treasure in this place or it cannot be found through normal means."

"Through normal means? How else can we locate a treasure besides our Divine Sense?" Yuan asked.

"There are treasures that can locate other treasures. There are also magical beasts with special senses that allow them to pick up treasure. There are even powerful arrays that can pinpoint treasures as long as it's within the array. There are many methods one can use to locate treasures. However, unless they're incredibly incompetent, the people of this sect should've already tried all of these methods throughout the years."

"If that's the case, perhaps there really is no treasure in this place, and this abundant spiritual energy is merely a natural phenomenon?" Yuan said.

"No, there's definitely a treasure in this place." Xiao Hua suddenly said. "Xiao Hua just analyzed the flow of the spiritual energy in this place, and it's not natural. Something here is attracting the spiritual energy to this place."

"Really? Then can you pinpoint what is causing this phenomenon?"

"No, Xiao Hua cannot find anything no matter how much she tries. Maybe one requires a special technique or treasure to find the treasure." Xiao Hua said.

"Hmmm? Special technique...?" Yuan raised his eyebrows as though he'd realized something.

'What if it's a treasure that can only be seen with the Dragon's Gaze? After all, the Founder also knew of this technique...' Yuan thought to himself.

With that in mind, Yuan activated the Dragon's Gaze and proceeded to look around. However, he found nothing out of the ordinary.

'Nothing? Maybe it's in a different area since this place seems very big.'

Thus, Yuan proceeded to walk around the Dragon's Peak as though he was taking a stroll while his eyes glowed gold and emitted an ancient aura.

"Nothing here..."

"Nothing out of the ordinary here either..."

Yuan spent the next two hours walking around the peak, but alas, he couldn't find the treasure.

'Perhaps there is really no treasure in this place? But Xiao Hua said there's definitely something manipulating the flow of spiritual energy in this place, hence the abundance of spiritual energy.'

After pondering for a moment, Yuan wondered if he needed to activate Divine Sense as well as Dragon's Gaze, so he proceeded to walk around the Dragon's Peak for the second time, but this time, he had both Dragon's Gaze and Divine Sense activated.

"Still nothing?" Yuan was truly puzzled now.

The Dragon's Peak was spacious but also very empty, so there are very few places one can hide a treasure.

The treasure could be hidden underground, but not even Xiao Hua could find the treasure with her Divine Sense that's powered by the cultivation of a Spirit King, so that was unlikely.

"If it's not hidden on the surface or underground, there's only one more place..."

Yuan slowly tilted his head until he was staring at the sky. However, there was nothing there.

"..."

After taking a deep breath, Yuan activated the Dragon's Gaze again.

"T-T-This is..."

Yuan subconsciously took a few steps back with a shocked look on his face when he saw the thing flying above the Dragon's Peak.

"What's the matter, Brother Yuan?" Xiao Hua asked him since she couldn't see anything in the sky.

Yuan pointed at the sky with his entire arm trembling, and he said, "There... There is a huge glowing dragon flying in the sky!"

"What? Xiao Hua cannot see anything in the sky," she quickly said.

"I am not lying! It's really there! It's circling around the area like a guardian of some sorts!" Yuan hastily said.

"..."

No matter how hard she tried to look, Xiao Hua couldn't see the dragon Yuan was talking about.

"Can you describe it, Brother Yuan?" she then asked.

"It's at least one... no, two hundred meters in length, and it doesn't appear to have a physical body— only a golden outline. It resembles the Great One I saw on the 100th floor in the tower." Yuan described the dragon to the best of his abilities.

"That sounds like..." Just as Xiao Hua opened her mouth to speak, Yuan suddenly said in a surprised voice.

"Oh, it just noticed me... and it's looking directly at me."

Yuan looked at the golden dragon in the sky that was also staring back at him with a profound gaze.

After a few moments of silence and stillness, suddenly, the dragon began moving.

"Eh?" Yuan's eyes widened with shock when he saw the dragon start to fly at him like a meteor, immediately sending chills down his spine.

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Chapter 265 - Dragon Essence

Seeing the golden dragon flying at him, Yuan subconsciously retrieved his Empyrean Overlord and took a defensive stance as it felt like an extremely powerful and violent beast was rushing at him at this moment.

"Brother Yuan?" Xiao Hua was puzzled by Yuan's sudden alertness and called out to him.

But alas, Yuan was too focused on the dragon to hear Xiao Hua's voice.

Whoosh!

The dragon slithered through the air in a smooth movement before headbutting Yuan.

Yuan held the Empyrean Overlord in front of his body to block the attack, but to his surprise, as though it was a ghost, the dragon went directly through his sword and straight into his body!

"Ah!" Yuan shouted in a surprised voice when the dragon suddenly invaded his body.

"What happened, Brother Yuan?!" Xiao Hua left the necklace and asked him.

"T-The golden dragon went inside my body!" He quickly said.

"Brother Yuan, Xiao Hua believes that the dragon is—"

Right as Xiao Hua spoke, a notification appeared before him.

Ding!

[Heaven Refining Physique activated]

[Minor Dragon Essence has been refined]

[Soul Strength +10,000]

[Your Divine Sense has reached a new level]

[Divine Sense Mastery Level (1) → (2)]

"—Dragon Essence, so it's not harmful to your body. In fact, it will even benefit you greatly!" Xiao Hua said.

"Dragon Essence? What is that? I just gained a lot of stats from absorbing the Minor Dragon Essence." Yuan said.

"What! Brother Yuan already absorbed the Dragon Essence?!" Xiao Hua looked at him with a gawking expression on her small face.

Unlike monster cores, monster essences are very unique in the way they are created and absorbed. When a magical beast dies, its Dantian will form into a monster core that allows Cultivators to absorb some of its spiritual energy. However, when it comes to essences, they can be created without needing the magical beasts' death.

With that being said, only powerful magical beasts have the ability to create essences, mostly Divine Beasts like the Great One, and even then it requires a lot of energy and time to form its own essence.

As for why magical beasts would waste their time and effort on creating essences— it's sort of training for them, like how Yuan trains his Divine Sense, as it strengthens their control over their own spiritual energy as well as their soul and mental strength.

"B-Brother Yuan, even though it's only a minor essence, it normally takes months if not years for an individual to fully absorb it, yet you managed to absorb it so quickly, almost instantaneously... It's almost as shocking as your eating habits..." Xiao Hua said to him with her eyes wide as saucers.

"Does absorbing monster essences not give you Qi like monster cores do?" Yuan asked her since he didn't get any Qi from absorbing the Dragon Essence.

"Essences are unique in the way that different essences will have different effects. Some essence can give you Qi while others will grant you other benefits such as increased physical strength or mental strength." Xiao Hua explained to him.

"I see... and the Dragon Essence happened to give me Soul Strength..." Yuan mumbled.

"WHAT!" Xiao Hua suddenly shouted in a shocked voice.

"S-Soul Strength?! The Dragon Essence gave Brother Yuan Soul Strength?! Is this true?!" Xiao Hua asked him in a somewhat nervous manner.

"Y-Yes..." Yuan nodded, startled by her reaction.

"That's incredibly lucky, Brother Yuan! Out of everything one can obtain from essences, Soul Strength is the rarest and most sought after essence by even top Cultivators since it directly improves your Soul Strength without needing any Soul Techniques or training!" Xiao Hua said to him in an excited voice, her body slightly shaking from excitement as though she was the one who received the benefit.

"Either the Founder of this place is incredibly generous to leave behind the Dragon Essence or he wasn't the one who put the Dragon Essence here!"

Yuan nodded and continued to ask, "By the way, it's only a Minor Dragon Essence. Does this mean there are even higher qualities of essences?"

Xiao Hua nodded and said, "That's right. There are Minor Essences, Major Essences, and Divine Essences."

"I see..." Yuan mumbled, and he continued, "What about methods one can use to find essences? This Dragon Essence was hidden in plain sight yet nobody managed to find it despite thousands of years."

However, Xiao Hua shook her head and said, "Just like how each essence has different effects, they also have different properties. Therefore, there is no single method to look for essences. They're all incredibly rare and can only be found by chance or fate."

"As for Brother Yuan... since only you managed to find it despite it being in plain sight for so many years, one can say the Dragon Essence was fated to be found by you. In other words, it's fate."

"Fate, huh..." Yuan suddenly recalled his meeting with Senior Bai and their talk about destiny and fate. Perhaps he was destined for this fortunate encounter.

Suddenly, another phenomenon occurred in the place, as all of the spiritual energy gathered at Dragon's Peak began dispersing in every direction.

"What's going on?" Yuan looked at the change with wide eyes.

Xiao Hua responded in a calm voice, "The Dragon Essence was what attracted the spiritual energy to this area. Now that it's gone since Brother Yuan absorbed it, there is no longer anything attracting the spiritual energy, so it's only natural they are leaving. Soon, this place will return to being a normal place without its abundance in spiritual energy."

"I see..."

Xiao Hua then continued, "Brother Yuan, you should take this opportunity to cultivate and absorb as much spiritual energy as you can since it'll take some time before the spiritual energy in this place returns to normal."

Yuan nodded and immediately sat down and began reciting his cultivation technique.

Whoosh!

The spiritual energy that was dispersing suddenly stopped leaving and began approaching Yuan as though they were attracted to him, quickly

creating a small tornado around him. However, Yuan could only feel a gentle and comfortable breeze around him.

Meanwhile, his cultivation base began to soar closer and closer to Spirit Master!

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Chapter 266 - Nine Dragon Symbols

Ding!

[Due to your title Pang City's Hero, cultivation speed has increased by 10%]

Ding!

[Due to your Untainted Body, cultivation speed has increased by 100%]

Ding!

[Environmental effect has increased your cultivation speed by 500%]

[+3,852 Qi]

[+3,946 Qi]

[+3,750 Qi]

[+3,656 Qi]

Due to his title and untainted body, Yuan's cultivation speed more than doubled, not to mention the Dragon's Peak that was abundant with spiritual energy. Yuan absorbed over 3,000 Qi every second, and in just a minute, he'd absorbed over two hundred thousand Qi.

Meanwhile, Xiao Hua sat in front of Yuan and watched him cultivate in silence.

'What a crazy cultivation speed for someone at the Spirit Warrior realm... He's absorbing the spiritual energy like he's eating food, almost like an unstoppable monster.' Xiao Hua thought to herself as she stared at Yuan's peaceful face with admiration on her face.

'At this rate, Brother Yuan will absorb enough spiritual energy to breakthrough to Spirit Master in a month... And even though Brother Yuan won't become a Spirit Master in time for the Mystic Realm, it's already an incredible feat, especially since we're still in the Lower Heavens where the quality of Qi isn't as good...'

After an hour of cultivation, unbeknownst to Yuan or Xiao Hua, inside Yuan's body, the Dragon Essence he'd absorbed just finished merging with the golden symbols engraved in his bones, causing them to change slightly before emitting a bright and golden glow.

Whoosh!

The spiritual energy in the area suddenly grew restless, and they began rushing toward Yuan's body as though Yuan's body had become a black hole with intense suction.

"W-What's going on?" Xiao Hua mumbled in a dazed voice when she noticed this sudden change, and it was unlike anything she has ever seen before.

Ding!

[Nine Dragon Symbols has been activated!]

[Nine Dragon Symbols have reached level one]

[Due to the Nine Dragon Symbols, your cultivation speed have increased by 1,000%]

Yuan's cultivation speed suddenly increased by a whopping 1,000 percent, shocking and puzzling Yuan at the same time, as he had no idea what this Nine Dragon Symbols was or how he'd obtained it.

However, he didn't think about it too much for now and decided to focus on cultivating, as he was worried that if he'd stopped, this sudden boost would disappear as well.

[+8,411 Qi]

[+8,301 Qi]

[+8,569 Qi]

His Qi gathering speed per second immediately doubled, allowing him to absorb over 8,000 Qi every single second, and in just an hour, Yuan had managed to absorb almost 30 million Qi!

Xiao Hua watched Yuan cultivate with her mouth wide open and jaw dropped. What caused this sudden and explosive increase in cultivation speed? Does it have anything to do with the Dragon Essence? However, she has never heard of essences having such a unique ability after being absorbed! After all, even though the Dragon Essence had the ability to gather spiritual energy at Dragon's Peak, such an ability shouldn't have transferred to Yuan after he absorbed it! Otherwise, it would be too powerful, and the heavens would never allow such a flaw to exist!

'Wait a second... Brother Yuan also managed to obtain a magical beast's ability after he consumed its monster core! Maybe he can also do the same with their essence? But that would be too...' Xiao Hua didn't know whether to laugh or cry at Yuan's unbelievable existence.

Whenever it feels like she has witnessed all there is to Yuan's talents, he would suddenly show even more talents like some sort of magic show! But instead of taking out a rabbit from his hat, Yuan takes out unbelievable talents that would leave anyone filled with jealousy if they knew about it!

After another 6 hours of cultivation, Yuan decided to finally stop cultivating as it was getting late.

"Hmm? Xiao Hua? You were sitting there this entire time?" Yuan finally noticed Xiao Hua sitting in front of him when he opened his eyes.

"Yes..." Xiao Hua nodded with a dazed look on her face.

"I made some really good progress today," Yuan said with a smile on his face, and then he asked, "By the way, do you know anything about the Nine Dragon Symbols?"

"Nine Dragon Symbols? Xiao Hua has never heard of that before. Is that a treasure?" she asked with a tilted head.

"I don't know, but I think that is what's causing the explosive increase in my cultivation speed."

"Nine Dragon Symbols... Perhaps the phoenix will know something." Xiao Hua then said.

Yuan nodded, "I'll ask her when she comes back."

A few moments later, Xiao Hua entered the necklace before Yuan logged off the game.

Once Meixiu returned, she immediately went to cook dinner as usual before feeding Yuan.

After feeding Yuan, Meixiu went to take a quick shower before retiring for the day inside her room.

"Let's see if his friend has arrived yet..."

Meixiu wore the helmet and immediately went inside Cultivation Online.

Once she was inside the game, Meixiu looked around the place, and she immediately noticed a small commotion right outside the city gates.

Meixiu narrowed her eyes at the crowd of people that appeared to be surrounding an individual—a very beautiful young woman wearing tight red robes and a very mature body.

"That must be her..." Meixiu mumbled to herself before she approached her.

"Excuse me..." Meixiu tried to push her way to the young woman in the red dress, but alas, the crowd was too strong for her to do anything.

"Get out of my way!" A clear voice suddenly resounded loudly.

The place immediately turned silent, and a path quickly appeared in the crowd.

A few moments later, the young woman in the seductive red clothes walked out of the crowd and stopped in front of Meixiu.

"A naturally bored face and someone who doesn't understand 'fun'... You fit the description the Young Master gave me. Are you the Young Master's friend?" Feng Yuxiang asked Meixiu.

"By Young Master, do you mean Yuan?" Meixiu asked.

Feng Yuxiang nodded and said, "Looks like I have found the right person. Come with me, I'll bring you to the Eastern Continent so you can meet with the Young Master."

Author's Note: For those confused about the numbers, it's Cultivation Speed x Base Qi Absorption Rate. Yuan's cultivation technique absorbs around 500 Qi per second, and it's 610% and 1610% of that 500, not 1000% of 3000.

Chapter 267 - A New Experience

After meeting with Meixiu, Feng Yuxiang hugged Meixiu's waist and flew towards the heavens as she did with Yu Rou, and they proceeded to make their way towards the Eastern Continent.

"T-This is..."

Meixiu was shocked when Feng Yuxiang suddenly brought her into the air, and when she looked down, her body began trembling nonstop uncontrollably.

"Hm? Are you scared of heights?" Feng Yuxiang asked Meixiu when she noticed her shaking.

"I... I..." Meixiu was speechless. Since she has never flown in a plane or went to any tall places before, she was never aware of her acrophobia. In other words, she was scared of heights.

"Don't worry, I won't accidentally drop you or anything. You can close your eyes, too." Feng Yuxiang suggested this to her.

Meixiu immediately closed her eyes, but the image of the distant ground still lingered inside her mind.

"By the way, if you don't mind me asking, what's your relationship with the Young Master? I know you're friends, but I want to know more about you and the Young Master." Feng Yuxiang suddenly asked her.

"A friend, huh? Is that what Yuan said?" A slight smile appeared on Meixiu's face.

"Hm? You're not friends? Then what are you to him?"

"I'm more of his caretaker— a servant so to speak," Meixiu said.

"Oh? You're his servant as well?" Feng Yuxiang said in a surprised tone.
"I'm also the Young Master's servant."

Meixiu opened her eyes again to look at Feng Yuxiang with wide eyes filled with surprise. How could someone like her be a servant? She looks like a powerful madam from an influential family more than anything.

"What's with that look? You don't believe me?" Feng Yuxiang raised her eyebrows at Meixiu's doubtful gaze.

"Yuan... He called you a phoenix. Are you really a phoenix?" Meixiu suddenly asked.

"That's right. I'm a phoenix, but I have my powers sealed right now so I cannot show you." Feng Yuxiang nodded.

"Is that so..."

The two of them became silent afterward, and it remained that way for a couple of minutes until Feng Yuxiang suddenly said, "We'll take the teleportation device that's at the city of Liyang, which is about four hours away."

"F-Four hours?" Meixiu was slightly surprised.

"How long do you think it'll take us to reach the Eastern Continent and meet up with Yuan? Do you think we'll make it before sunrise?"

While Meixiu didn't mind losing sleep for a single night, she couldn't neglect Yuan's breakfast no matter what.

"By sunrise, huh? It's definitely doable, but I don't know if you'll be able to handle the speed, since you're a mortal..." Feng Yuxiang said to her.

"I will be fine," said Meixiu.

"If you say so..." Feng Yuxiang nodded, and she immediately raised her flying speed, nearly doubling it.

"!!!"

Meixiu could feel her chest tightening from the speed increase. Even though Feng Yuxiang shielded Meixiu from most of the wind pressure with her spiritual energy, it was still very powerful for a mortal who hasn't even started cultivating yet.

Meanwhile, inside his own room, Yuan tried to activate his Divine Sense again.

'Monster cores don't affect my real life cultivation when I consume them inside the game, but monster essences might be a different case... Hopefully, the Dragon Essence will finally enable me to use my Divine Sense in this world as well...'

With that in mind, Yuan took a deep breath and tried to activate his Divine Sense.

"..."

"..."

"..."

Yuan could feel his spiritual energy reacting to his attempt, but in the end, he was still unable to activate his Divine Sense.

'I still can't activate my Divine Sense, however, there was a response at least! It shouldn't be long before I can actually use my Divine Sense! Maybe if I raise a couple more levels...'

Even though Yuan couldn't activate his Divine Sense yet, he was feeling more motivated and hopeful than ever.

Thus, Yuan began cultivating.

However, immediately after he began cultivating, Yuan noticed something different about his cultivation speed— it'd suddenly increased again.

While it isn't as explosive as his cultivation improvements in Cultivation Online, it was still a pretty big difference compared to the last time he'd cultivated, and his cultivation quickly moved towards 5th level Spirit Warrior.

Two hours have passed since Feng Yuxiang and Meixiu met, and they'd just arrived at the city of Liyang, arriving two hours earlier than anticipated.

Feng Yuxiang landed directly in front of the city's entrance, shocking the guards there.

"Seniors!"

Everybody there bowed to Feng Yuxiang when they landed, startling Meixiu who knew nothing about Cultivators and their culture. It was a new experience for her.

"How may we help you, Esteemed Seniors?" The guards in front of them said before bowing to them again.

"We're here to use the teleportation device," said Feng Yuxiang.

"I understand. Please, follow us."

The guard proceeded to lead Feng Yuxiang and Meixiu into the city and towards the teleportation device.

On the way, Meixiu looked around the scenery and the people there with a somewhat intrigued gaze.

Since she rarely leaves the house and only goes out to go to school with Yu Rou, Meixiu doesn't have much experience in the outside world.

"You're somewhat different from what the Young Master described." Feng Yuxiang suddenly said to her.

"Me? What did he say about me?" Meixiu asked her with a curious look.

Feng Yuxiang smiled and said, "The Young Master said it's hard for you to find entertainment in things, almost like you're always bored."

"I see..."

To Feng Yuxiang's surprise, a somewhat sweet smile appeared on Meixiu's face.

Sometime later, they arrived at the teleportation device.

"Where would you like to go, Esteemed Seniors?" The guard guiding them asked.

"The Eastern Continent." Feng Yuxiang immediately responded.

"The Eastern Continent... That's a little bit far..." A perplexed expression appeared on the guard's face.

Seeing the guard's face, Feng Yuxiang continued, "Don't worry, we're not going to use the teleportation device for free. I'll pay for it."

The guard's expression immediately relaxed after hearing Feng Yuxiang's words, and he quickly nodded, "I understand! Please, follow me to the front!"

Chapter 268 - Nothing Is Impossible In The Cultivation World!

"Excuse me! Coming through!"

The guard forcefully led Feng Yuxiang and Meixiu through the crowd that was waiting in line for their turn at the teleportation device.

This caused the people already in line to frown, especially since most of them were from somewhat big families, and this was a slap in the face to them since they had to stand in line like everybody else.

"Hey! What gives? How come they get to skip the line while the rest of us stand here?! What's so special about them?!" Someone in the line suddenly shouted out loud in a frustrated voice, calling them out.

"That's right! Do you know who I am?!"

"I'll complain to the Mayor!"

The guard quickly turned around and responded to that person in a sarcastic voice, "Well, if you have the ability to fly, I will also allow you to skip the line. How does that sound?"

"Fly?"

The people there raised their eyebrows in a puzzled manner.

"Do you have a problem with us going first?" Feng Yuxiang suddenly turned around and spoke, even releasing a little bit of her Spirit

Grandmaster cultivation base.

"S-Spirit Grandmaster!"

The people there were immensely shocked by Feng Yuxiang's cultivation base. Just where on earth did this Spirit Grandmaster come from? And how come they don't recognize her?

"Please forgive us, Senior Grandmaster!"

The people there quickly lowered their heads and apologized to Feng Yuxiang.

Feng Yuxiang didn't say anything else and continued to approach the teleportation device with Meixiu following behind her.

'How overbearing...' Meixiu thought to herself, yet she found it somewhat admirable.

A few moments later, they arrived in front of the teleportation device.

"Esteemed Seniors, because the Eastern Continent is very far away, we can only teleport you to three places. Are you fine with that?" The person managing the teleportation device asked them.

Feng Yuxiang nodded and said, "Teleport us to the one closest to the Dragon Essence Temple."

"The Dragon Essence Temple, right? Give me a moment to look at the map..."

The worker proceeded to look at the large map that was pinned to a portable board nearby; it had the location of every city in the Lower Heavens with a teleportation device.

"That would be the Iron Lotus City, which is approximately 290,000 miles from our current location. As for the price... It will be 3,400,000 gold, Esteemed Seniors."

'3,400,000 gold!' Meixiu was inwardly shocked when she heard the astronomical amount of gold needed to use the teleportation device.

Yu Rou had told her about the exchange rates for Cultivation Online gold and real-life money, and it was about one gold for every seven dollars. In this case, 3,400,000 gold was worth at least 23,800,000 dollars!

This amount of money is more than enough to feed an entire family luxuriously for their entire life, and they're going to spend all of it on transportation? Not even the richest family in their world would dare to spend so lavishly.

'Just how on earth did Yuan make someone like her into his servant?' Meixiu couldn't help but become curious.

"Here's 2,500 spirit stones. Keep the change." Feng Yuxiang handed a storage pouch to the worker in a nonchalant manner, acting as though she was only buying some cheap food.

"T-Thank you very much, Esteemed Senior! Please give me a moment to prepare the teleportation device for you."

The worker accepted the storage pouch with excitement before counting the spirit stones inside.

Once he confirmed the payment, the worker went to set the settings on the teleportation device so it would teleport them to their desired location.

A few minutes later, the worker returned to them and said, "The teleportation device is ready. Just let me know when and I'll activate it. Once activated, you have 60 seconds to enter the teleportation device before it loses power."

Feng Yuxiang turned to look at Meixiu and asked her, "Are you ready?"

Meixiu nodded.

"Let's go then."

The two of them stood before the teleportation device a few moments later, and once the worker activated the device, they walked into the portal.

Meixiu felt a little dizzy after entering the teleportation device and the feeling lingered for some time even after the teleportation was finished.

"Are you okay?" Feng Yuxiang asked her.

"Yes... Just a little dizzy."

"I'm surprised you didn't throw up since mortals can't handle much spiritual energy, and you'd just walked through a portal created from a large amount of spiritual energy." Feng Yuxiang said to her.

And she continued, "You must have a strong soul strength. Makes me wonder why you're not a Cultivator. You might have the talent for it."

"I... have no reason to become a Cultivator," Meixiu said.

After all, she only joined the game so she could help Yuan out.

"No reason? There are plenty of reasons for one to become a Cultivator! Wealth, fame, status, power... Do you not have desires?" Feng Yuxiang asked her.

"My desire..." A certain thought appeared in her mind.

"I do have one, but becoming a Cultivator won't help me realize that dream. It's impossible." Meixiu shook her head.

"Impossible? Nothing is impossible in the cultivation world! At least this is what I learned after following the Young Master for a short time."

"Yuan?" Meixiu raised her eyebrows.

Feng Yuxiang nodded and said, "That's right. The Young Master is an incredible existence with a limitless future. I have only been with him for a few weeks and I can only imagine how strong he'll grow in the future."

"Anyways, we can continue this conversation later. Are you still dizzy? We won't make it to the Dragon Essence Temple by sunrise if we linger around for too long." Feng Yuxiang said to her.

"I am okay. We can continue." Meixiu nodded.

"Okay."

The two of them returned to the air shortly later, and Feng Yuxiang continued chatting with Meixiu like they were already friends while they soared in the clouds. Perhaps it was due to their similar background as Yuan's servant, but Feng Yuxiang found Meixiu to be an interesting individual who was very different from the average person.

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Chapter 269 - We Should Play Together

Splash!

Right as the sun began rising at the horizon in the real world, a refreshing sensation surged from Yuan's body as he made a breakthrough and reached 5th level Spirit Warrior.

After the breakthrough, Yuan stopped cultivating and tried to activate his Divine Sense again.

A few moments later, he stopped and thought to himself, 'I still can't activate my Divine Sense, but I can feel its progress. Just a little more...'

Meanwhile, inside the game, Feng Yuxiang said to Meixiu after flying for many hours without rest, "I can see the Dragon Essence Temple. We've arrived."

"Hmm?"

Meixiu, who was just asleep, slowly opened her eyes to see the Dragon Essence Temple in the distance.

"This is a sect? It looks no different than a city," she mumbled.

"Most sects are a city itself, but unlike normal cities, only its disciples or approved guests are allowed inside. Furthermore, there are no businesses in sects. While there may be a few, it's all set up by the sect and not for profit." Feng Yuxiang explained to her.

"Anyways, it's sunrise. Let's get you to the Young Master's living quarters."

Feng Yuxiang then silently flew towards the Dragon Essence Temple before landing in the backyard of Yuan's living quarters a few minutes later since she didn't have the keys to the house.

Once they landed, Meixiu said to Feng Yuxiang, "Thank you for bringing me here, Senior Feng. I have to leave now."

Feng Yuxiang nodded, "I was just doing my job. Anyways, you can call me Feng Feng like the Young Master."

Meixiu logged off the game shortly later whilst Feng Yuxiang relaxed in the backyard to wait for Yuan to return.

After logging off the game, Meixiu removed the helmet from her head and sat on the bed with a somewhat dazed look on her face.

"Cultivation Online... What an experience... It really felt like I was living in another world just now." Meixiu mumbled to herself, and she finally understood why the hype and popularity for this game existed, as it was completely justified.

After sitting there for a few moments, Meixiu stood up and went to prepare breakfast for Yuan, and to her surprise, she didn't feel any fatigue or sleepy like she'd expected after staying inside the game for the entire night.

While the soup cooked, Meixiu went to wash her face, brush her teeth, and prepare for school.

Once breakfast was prepared, Meixiu knocked on Yuan's room and said, "It's time for breakfast."

"I'm awake." Yuan's voice resounded.

Meixiu opened the door and pushed the mini cart inside his room.

"I met with Feng Feng last night, and she took me from the Western Continent to the Eastern Continent, even arriving at your living quarters right before I logged off," Meixiu said as she fed Yuan breakfast.

"Oh? Already? That was quicker than I'd expected. How did it go? Did you enjoy it?" Yuan asked her.

"..."

After a moment of silence, Meixiu said, "Yes, I enjoyed it. It was a unique and mythical experience. Meeting Feng Feng, learning about cultivators and the cultivation world, using the teleportation device, and the most shocking experience of all— flying in the sky."

"As long as you had fun. I know you only intend on playing the game so you can help me sell items and gold, but you should really consider playing with me. We can travel the cultivation world and experience everything together."

Meixiu's eyes widened when she heard Yuan's unexpected words, which left her speechless for a good moment.

"What do you think, Meixiu? You're always working, even as a child. In fact, I think we're very similar, in the sense that we're always working for the same place. If it weren't for my sudden condition, I'm pretty sure that I would still be working for the Yu Family even right now. This may sound crazy, but I no longer see my condition as a curse. Perhaps it is even a blessing in disguise."

"Telling me to play with you... Is that a command?" Meixiu suddenly asked him.

"Of course not. It's a request, Meixiu. If you don't want to play with me, that's fine. However, from your words just now, I could tell that you really enjoyed your time in Cultivation Online. If that's the case, you might as well continue playing. You might even find another purpose in life besides working as I did."

"Are you really fine with me being by your side in Cultivation Online as well?" Meixiu asked again, her voice sounding somewhat nervous.

"Why did you make it sound like I can't stand your presence? Even though we've always been near each other for almost our entire lives, I've never once had such thoughts, and we've never really played together before. This is a great opportunity to do so."

"But I don't really have the time..." Meixiu sighed.

"It's fine. We can play together whenever you're free or don't have school on the weekends. I also don't mind missing a meal once in a while so we can play more." Yuan said with a smile on his face.

After a moment of silence, Meixiu said, "Okay. I understand. I'll play with you."

"That's great!"

After breakfast, Meixiu went to school with Yu Rou whilst Yuan continued his training inside cultivation online.

"Oh, right. I should go meet with Feng Feng first since she's probably waiting for me—"

Right as Yuan thought about returning to his living quarters to meet up with Feng Yuxiang, a trail of flames could be seen traveling in the sky like a shooting star, flying toward Yuan's location.

And for some reason, Yuan immediately recognized this flame.

"Feng Feng?"

A few moments later, Feng Yuxiang entered Yuan's body.

"I'm back, Young Master," she said to him afterward.

"Welcome back, Feng Feng. And thank you for your hard work. I'll let you drink some of my blood later." Yuan said to her.

"Really? Thank you, Young Master!" Feng Yuxiang's excited voice quickly resounded, as it has been some time since she tasted his delicious blood.

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Chapter 270 - Three Years Old

After Feng Yuxiang returned to his body, Yuan sat down on the soft ground and began his cultivation.

The still atmosphere suddenly changed when Yuan started to absorb the spiritual energy in the air, and a small tornado appeared around him once again.

[+8,174 Qi]

[+8,412 Qi]

[+8,059 Qi]

Feng Yuxiang was greatly shocked when she saw this, as she'd just returned and didn't know about the Dragon Essence.

"What's happening? Did the Young Master consume a treasure that increased his cultivation speed?" Feng Yuxiang decided to ask Xiao Hua using her spiritual sense.

"Brother Yuan absorbed a Minor Dragon Essence, which gave him not only increased Soul Strength but also cultivation speed... I think." Xiao Hua responded to her.

"What! Dragon Essence?! Soul Strength! That's the rarest property one can obtain from essences! How lucky!" Feng Yuxiang grew even more shocked after hearing this.

"Wait... Cultivation speed? I have never heard of essences giving such an effect before," she suddenly realized.

"You may not know this, but Brother Yuan not only has the ability to consume monster cores. He can even obtain their abilities after consuming them. Perhaps it also applies to essences."

"What! That's impos—"

Feng Yuxiang wanted to say that such a thing couldn't be possible, but after recalling Yuan's unfathomable talents and his legendary physique, she decided to not continue that sentence.

After a moment of silence, Xiao Hua suddenly spoke, "Phoenix, you're a Divine Beast as well, right? Why don't you create some Phoenix Essence for Brother Yuan."

"You make it sound like it's easy making essence..." Feng Yuxiang responded in a sighing voice.

"I also have my powers sealed, so I cannot do that in a reasonable amount of time. Perhaps once the curse is lifted, I will be able to create some Phoenix Essence for the Young Master, but in my current condition, that's impossible."

Yuan cultivated in silence, not moving from that spot for ten hours straight.

At the end of the day, he'd obtained a little over 300 million Qi. In just two days, Yuan had managed to accumulate around 500 million Qi, which is enough Qi for someone at first level Spirit Apprentice to enter 4th level Spirit Warrior.

After he stopped cultivating, Yuan logged off the game to wait for Meixiu to return from school.

Sometime later, Meixiu returned home, cooked dinner, and began feeding Yuan.

"Yuan... Can I ask you why you decided to use this name?" Meixiu suddenly asked him.

"..."

After a moment of silence, Yuan said, "That was my name before I was adopted."

"Eh?"

Meixiu's eyes widened slightly from surprise. Now that she thought about it, she didn't know anything about Yuan's life before he was adopted into the Yu Family.

"As you already know, I was adopted into the Yu Family when I was just three years old. Yu Rou was still a baby at that time so she doesn't know about it. I don't know my real parents and when I was in the orphanage, everyone would call me Yuan."

"I see..."

"Do you know why I was adopted into the Yu Family in the first place?" Yuan suddenly asked her.

"I do not..." Meixiu said.

"Someone had posted to the internet a video of a three-year-old playing a piano, which immediately became an internet sensation. Of course, that kid was me, and when the Yu Family saw that video, they decided to adopt me and trained me so I can play for the family— at least that's why I think I was adopted. Otherwise, I cannot imagine the Yu Family adopting me for any other reason."

Meixiu was speechless after learning this for the first time. So the Yu Family adopted Yuan merely for his musical talents? Of course, this made sense and wasn't too shocking considering how the Yu Family treated him after Yuan could no longer play the instruments.

"I'm sorry..." Meixiu suddenly apologized to him.

"Why are you apologizing to me? You're not the one at fault here." Yuan chuckled.

"I know, but I am also part of the Yu Family." Meixiu sighed.

Once dinner was finished, Meixiu went to do her necessities before going to sleep.

'Even though I missed sleep last night, I didn't feel tired or sleepy at all during school today. How weird...' Meixiu thought to herself

Although she was trained to do her job even with very little to no sleep, it was odd for her to feel no fatigue despite lacking sleep.

The following day, Yuan returned to Cultivation Online and proceeded to spend another 10 hours cultivating, bringing the total of Qi absorbed to 800 million.

'I am still about 2 billion Qi away from Spirit Master... I might now make it to Spirit Master before the Mystic Realm even with my increased cultivation speed.' Yuan thought to himself.

Three days later, Yuan absorbed another 900 million Qi, accumulated 1.7 billion Qi.

Meanwhile, at Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower, the gamble between Long Yijun and the other Sect Master has finally come to an end.

"Hahaha!" Long Yijun exploded with laughter as the last disciple walked out of the tower with a defeated look on his face, the results obvious.

"Looks like none of your disciples were able to defeat all 100 floors! I win this bet! Now, hand over your treasures!" Long Yijun said to the fuming Sect Masters with a wide smug on his face.

"This isn't the end, Sect Master Long! We'll be back after the Mystic Realm!" The Sect Masters there said to him as they reluctantly retrieved their Divine-grade treasures and handed them to Long Yijun in front of the spectators, shocking them greatly.

"Heavens! I thought this entire event was just for show! To think there was so much on the line!" The disciples watched with salivating mouths as Long Yijun held four Divine-grade treasures at once.

"We're leaving!" The other Sect Masters didn't dare to stay any longer and said to their disciples.

"You're leaving already? Don't you want to stay behind a little longer? Perhaps we can sit down for a drink or something!" Long Yijun said to them in a sarcastic voice.

"Hmph!"

The Sect Masters pretended they couldn't hear him and disappeared from the Dragon Essence Temple without looking back.

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Chapter 271 - Last Two Spots

After the Sect Masters and their disciples left, Long Yijun returned to his headquarters with the other high-ranking sect elders.

"Hahaha! What a bunch of idiots! They really thought they were going to defeat the tower!" Long Yijun laughed merrily as he looked at the four Divine-grade treasures in his grasp.

"Sect Master, what should we do now? While it's great that we've obtained these Divine-grade treasures, I highly doubt the other sects will just let us keep them." Elder Xuan suddenly asked.

And he continued, "They'll definitely come back for them."

Long Yijun stopped laughing after hearing Elder Xuan's words and nodded with a serious look on his face, "I am well aware of that. We also have no need for these Divine-grade treasures, so I intend on selling it back to them."

"How much do you intend on selling it for?" Elder Bai suddenly asked.

Long Yijun showed a malicious grin and said, "The full price, of course!"

The sect elders were startled, but they were not shocked by Long Yijun's response.

A Divine-grade treasure is not something one can just buy even if they have enough money— at least not in the Lower Heavens where it's extremely scarce, especially when they are powerful treasures that have been passed down for generations.

If the Dragon Essence Temple had lost their Dragon Slaying Saber, despite their wealth, they would have needed to sacrifice a few decades of resources at the very least to purchase it back from the other sects. That's how ridiculously priceless these Divine-grade treasures were.

However, unless the other sects are willing to wage war against the Dragon Essence Temple to get their treasures back, they could only grit their teeth and pay the Dragon Essence Temple every coin for their treasures back.

"By the way, how's Disciple Yuan? Is he currently training at Dragon's Peak?" Long Yijun suddenly asked Elder Xuan.

"Yes, I took him there the same day you asked me. However, Disciple Fei is currently in closed cultivation, so she will have to enter the Dragon's Peak at another time," said Elder Xuan.

Long Yijun nodded and said, "That's fine. With the Mystic Realm right around the corner, the most important thing right now is making sure Disciple Yuan is prepared."

"Although we don't know what will happen in the Mystic Realm this year, it's definitely not going to be easy even with Disciple Yuan assisting us. Therefore, we need to make sure he has everything he needs."

"By the way, Sect Master, it appears that there are many people looking for Disciple Yuan. It's also why we've been bombarded with visitors lately. Apparently, they are here for Disciple Yuan, and Disciple Yuan doesn't want to be found by them— at least that's what I think."

"What? Who are these people looking for Disciple Yuan? And what do they want from him?" Long Yijun immediately frowned.

"We only know that these people are mostly rogue cultivators without any backgrounds. The sect elders have questioned a few of them, and these rogue cultivators all say the same thing— 'I just want to speak with 'Player Yuan'," said Elder Xuan.

"Player Yuan? Is that Disciple Yuan's title or something?" Long Yijun raised his eyebrows in a puzzled manner.

And then he said, "Anyways, regardless of their reason, if Disciple Yuan doesn't want to be bothered by these people, we will assist him. Tighten up the security. Nobody is allowed near the sect unless authorized by me from now on. If they dare get close, beat them up!"

Hearing Long Yijun's command, the sect elders responded, "Yes, Sect Master!"

"One more thing, Sect Master. This is regarding the last two spots for the Mystic Realm." Elder Shan said a moment later, and she continued, "Do we have any names yet?"

"I was just about to bring this topic up." Long Yijun nodded.

"Does anyone here have any recommendations? I've been too focused on Disciple Yuan and haven't paid much attention to the other Core Disciples."

"Well... Besides Disciple Yuan, I can only think of two disciples who qualify for the Mystic Realm." Elder Bai said.

"So you're also thinking about those two, huh?" Long Yijun mumbled.

He then looked around and asked, "Do any of you have objections to letting those two disciples participate in the Mystic Realm with Disciple Yuan?"

Elder Shan then asked, "Just to be clear, these two disciples are..."

"It's Gao Dongya and Xue Jiye," said Long Yijun.

Gao Dongya is the current leader on the Core Disciple's Power Ranking. He only became a Core Disciple three years ago and immediately shot up the rankings within months, reaching first place in less than a year of becoming a Core Disciple, and he has been in that position since then like an immovable mountain.

As for Xue Jiye, while she is only ranked 13th in the leaderboards, she only recently became a Core Disciple half a year ago. In terms of talents and potential, she was on par with Gao Dongya.

"When should we make the announcement?" Elder Xuan then asked.

"Tomorrow." Long Yijun immediately responded.

The sect elders there nodded their heads.

Meanwhile, in the real world, after dinner, Yuan said to Meixiu, "The Mystic Realm is coming up and I am very close to making a breakthrough, so I will stay in the game tonight to cultivate."

"Okay." Meixiu agreed without any complaints.

Thus, Yuan went back into the game sometime later, and he proceeded to spend the entire night cultivating. While increasing his cultivation in the real world is important, he also didn't want to disappoint those who were counting on him for the Mystic Realm.

[+8,019 Qi]

[+8,132 Qi]

[+8,252 Qi]

After spending the entire night cultivating, Yuan gained another 250 million Qi, moving towards Spirit Master at a rapid rate!

'I have only about a billion Qi left. If I continue to cultivate at this pace for two more days, I should be able to breakthrough to Spirit Master!' Yuan thought to himself as he logged off at sunrise for breakfast before returning to the game for another day of cultivation.

Chapter 272 - The Three Names

Early in the morning shortly after sunrise, Long Yijun summoned all of the Core Disciples within the Dragon Essence Temple.

Once they received this summoning, regardless of what they were doing, even if they were in closed cultivation at the Immortal Caves, the Core Disciples gathered at the location of the gathering within an hour.

"I was wondering when they'll announce this year's participants for the Mystic Realm."

"Right? They usually announce it a month before the Mystic Realm, but this year they waited until the very last minute."

The Core Disciples there mumbled to each other while they waited for Long Yijun to show up.

"I was getting worried that they might've forgotten about it for a second."

"Forget about the Mystic Realm that will determine a sect's ranking? Nobody would forget such an important event!"

"Who do you think will get the spots for the Mystic Realm?"

"I think we all know who'll be occupying the first and second spot."

"It'll probably be Gao Dongya and Xue Jiye, right?"

"Probably? You mean most likely? Out of all of us, they're the most prominent in terms of potential. The only question is who'll get the third spot."

"What about Liang Qichao? He's always mentioned when one talks about Gao Dongya and Xue Jiye."

"It's possible, but who knows, really. Everyone here has a chance to obtain that third spot."

While the Core Disciples there made their guesses on who'll occupy the third spot, Fei Yuyan stood at the back of the crowd like a bystander with a nonchalant look on her face.

'Even though he's not a Core Disciple, it's already obvious that they'll pick him for the third spot...' The image of Yuan's handsome face appeared in Fei Yuyan's head as she thought about him.

Suddenly, someone tapped her on the shoulder, causing her to turn around.

"What do you want?" Fei Yuyan immediately frowned after seeing Xuan Wuhan standing behind her with an innocent-looking smile on her face.

"Who do you think will get the third spot for the Mystic Realm?" Xuan Wuhan suddenly asked her.

Fei Yuyan silently looked at her for a moment before speaking, "You should already know the answer to that question. Are you making fun of me?"

"You're no fun at all." Xuan Wuhan shrugged, and then she continued, "Are you disappointed?"

"Why would I be? I never hoped to be picked for the Mystic Realm in the first place." Fei Yuyan said.

"Haaa..." Xuan Wuhan sighed and said, "Sometimes I wonder why you're even in the Dragon Essence Temple. You would fit more with the Heavenly Melody Academy instead."

"..."

Fei Yuyan remained silent at her remarks.

A few moments later, someone there suddenly said, "Look! It's Gao Dongya! He's managed to break through to the 7th level of the Spirit Warrior realm during his closed cultivation!"

"Heavens! Another breakthrough? When was his last breakthrough? Four months ago? I swear, it feels like he's always one level higher every time I see him. At this rate, he'll reach Spirit Master before he turns 30! What monstrous talents!"

A handsome young man with long black hair, eyes, and wearing a black disciple uniform could be seen slowly walking towards the disciples with a nonchalant look on his face, causing the disciples there to swallow nervously when they were met by his gaze.

Once Gao Dongya arrived at the gathering area, the place grew significantly quieter.

Though, a couple of female disciples there approached him and began trying to start a conversation with him.

"Senior Brother Gao, congratulations on getting a spot. Although it hasn't been announced yet, we're confident that you'll definitely be picked."

"Congratulations on your breakthrough, Senior Brother Gao. We should have a celebration or something at my living quarters later."

The other Core Disciples acted as though they couldn't hear their obvious flirting as it was a common sight for the top disciples to have admirers.

"Che. What a bunch of sluts. Just wait until they learn about Yuan. I won't be surprised even if they removed their clothes on the spot for him. Don't you think so, Disciple Fei?" Xuan Wuhan asked her in a low voice.

"..."

Fei Yuyan looked at Xuan Wuhan with disbelief on her face, but she managed to resist herself from responding to that claim in the end.

A few minutes later, the disciples began talking again as a pretty young lady approached the crowd.

"Looks like Xue Jiye also experienced a breakthrough. Third level Spirit Warrior at 20 years old. Her talents are definitely on par with Gao Dongya if not slightly behind."

And just like how the female disciples surrounded Gao Dongya, some of the male disciples there approached Xue Jiye and began trying to strike a conversation with her.

"Congratulations on your breakthrough, Fairy Xue. Just a glance and I can already tell that you've become prettier."

"Fairy Xue, how about we have breakfast at the Dragon Pavilion after this gathering? It'll be my treat."

Sometime later, Long Yijun and a few of the higher ranking sect elders such as Elder Xuan and Elder Shan arrived at the gathering area.

"Greetings, Sect Master! Greetings, Grand Elders!"

Every disciple there lowered their heads and greeted them the moment they got close enough.

After standing still, Long Yijun spoke in a loud voice, "I'm sure you all know why I gathered all of you here today. The Mystic Realm is in four days, and we will be announcing the disciples that were chosen to represent the Dragon Essence Temple and participate in the Mystic Realm right now!"

Long Yijun cleared his throat before going straight into the subject without any speeches like usual, "The disciples that will be participating in the Mystic Realm will be Disciple Gao Dongya and Disciple Xue Jiye!"

The Core Disciples didn't react much to the announcement since they had already expected this result, and they all patiently waited for the third name.

However, to the disciples' surprise, Long Yijun said in a calm voice, "That's all."

"What?"

The disciples' eyes widened with shock and disbelief. What about the third spot? There should be three disciples in total participating in the Mystic Realm! Where's the third name?! What happened to the third spot?!

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Chapter 273 - Whos The Third Disciple?

Chapter 273 - Who's The Third Disciple?

"S-Sect Master! That's only two names! What happened to the third spot? I thought we were given three spots for the Mystic Realm?!" One of the disciples there decided to ask him.

Long Yijun turned to look at the disciple who just spoke and responded in a calm voice, "Indeed, the Dragon Essence Temple has been given three spots, and there will be three disciples participating in the Mystic Realm. However, I won't be naming the third disciple for now."

Long Yijun's words dumbfounded the disciples. He won't be naming the third disciple? Is it because they haven't decided on the third person yet or do they want to keep this individual hidden for some reason?

"..."

Gao Dongya narrowed his eyes with an uncertain expression on his face.

Meanwhile, Xue Jiye raised her eyebrows and thought to herself, 'The Sect Master is clearly trying to hide this individual... But why?'

After pondering for a moment, the image of two glowing golden eyes behind a black jade mask appeared in her thoughts, causing her body to tremble.

'It couldn't be!' Xue Jiye cried inwardly after recalling the cultivation prodigy who'd managed to comprehend 100 percent of the Tablet of Comprehension when she participated as an observer.

While the Dragon Essence Temple has never sent a disciple that wasn't a Core Disciple to the Mystic Realm, there were no rules stating that it must be a Core Disciple!

'It's possible! That masked person might take the third spot!' Xue Jiye thought to herself.

However, she hasn't heard of this person ever since the disciple examination ended.

'What happened to that person, anyway? Did he join the sect? Or did he leave?' Xue Jiye wondered to herself, feeling the desire to meet with this cultivation genius once again.

Sometime later, another disciple raised his hands and asked, "Sect Master, does that mean you've already picked a disciple for the third spot or you're still thinking?"

The disciples there swallowed nervously after hearing that question, as they also had the same question in their mind.

Long Yijun quickly responded, "The third spot is already occupied by a disciple."

"If that's the case, why can't you tell us who this disciple is? While we have no complaints about Disciple Gao and Disciple Xue participating in the Mystic Realm since they definitely qualify more than us, we cannot say the same for this third disciple," said a disciple.

And he continued, "And if I'm correct, we're allowed to challenge the sect's decision if we, the Core Disciples, believe that someone isn't qualified to participate in the Mystic Realm, as that's how it's always been."

"Indeed, you may challenge the sect's decision. However, that only applies when the disciple in question is questionable. In this case, it is without a doubt that this disciple qualifies for the Mystic Realm." Long Yijun said in a confident voice.

The disciples exchanged puzzled glances with each other. Just who is this disciple that has so much support and confidence from the Sect Master? Hell, even the sect elders there showed no signs of doubt, clearly showing their support for the Sect Master.

Seeing the doubtful atmosphere, Long Yijun suddenly smiled and said, "How about this? I am willing to bet my position as Sect Master of this sect that this disciple will, without a doubt, bring the Dragon Essence Temple to at least rank 3 at the Mystic Realm. If we achieve any less, I will resign from my position."

"WHAT?!"

Not just the disciples but even the sect elders there were greatly baffled by Long Yijun's announcement.

"S-Sect Master! That's a little..." Elder Xuan said to him in a nervous voice.

While he also believes that Yuan would achieve a high rank in the Mystic Realm, nothing in this world is certain, especially when it comes to the Mystic Realm.

"Sect Master, you don't have to do that. We won't doubt your decision any longer, so please, take back that statement!"

The disciples said to him in a panicked manner, as they couldn't have expected such a turn of events.

However, Long Yijun remained resolute and said, "This is not about your trust in me—but my trust in this disciple and my own judgment! If my judgment turns out to be wrong and it costs the Dragon Essence Temple the Mystic Realm, I don't deserve to be the Sect Master! That's all!"

The place quickly turned dead silent as nobody there could find any words to say to Long Yijun who was clearly very adamant about keeping to his words.

"Does anyone here have anything else to say before I let you all go?" Long Yijun asked them after a moment of silence.

The disciples remained silent, as their only question could not be answered at this moment.

"Then everybody but Gao Dongya and Xue Jiye may leave." Long Yijun said to them a few moments later.

Once all of the disciples beside the two Mystic Realm participants left, Long Yijun said to them, "Follow me."

Gao Dongya and Xue Jiye nodded their heads before following Long Yijun back to the sect master's headquarters, where Long Yijun proceeded to give them more details about the Mystic Realm.

"As you already know, the Mystic Realm is a month-long event where disciples from their respective sect must work together to obtain points by accomplishing feats within the Mystic Realm. Of course, this means that the sects with more slots have the advantage since they have more hands helping each other. But don't worry, I am confident that even with three people, we'll do fine. Teamwork is a must in the Mystic Realm, and I want the two of you to get used to each other over the next four days."

Hearing Long Yijun's words, Gao Dongyu spoke in a calm voice, "If that's the case, wouldn't it be better if all three participants are here? How can we strengthen our relationships with each other if one of us is missing?"

Long Yijun then said, "He's currently cultivating at Dragon's Peak right now so that's impossible. However, once he's done, I will definitely let you guys meet."

Chapter 274 - Rainbow Koi

"He's training at Dragon's Peak?"

Both Gao Dongya and Xue Jiye were surprised by this since even Core Disciples such as them would need to go through a lot of trouble before they're allowed to cultivate there.

"Anyways, let's continue." Long Yijun said, and he proceeded to speak more about the Mystic Realm to the two disciples.

Meanwhile, at Dragon's Peak, Yuan suddenly stopped cultivating and stood up before shouting, "Oh no! I totally forgot about the lecture for the Inner Court disciple!"

"Eh? Lecture?" Fang Yuxiang asked him.

"It was supposed to happen after the Inner Court Disciple Examination, but I'd forgotten about it because of the Dragon Essence! What a blunder... I hope my absence didn't cause any inconvenience..." he sighed.

"It's just a lecture, Young Master. You should be more worried about the Mystic Realm than some introduction class." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Oh, right. Speaking of the Mystic Realm, do you know anything about this place, Xiao Hua, Feng Feng?" Yuan asked after sitting down again.

"No, Xiao Hua doesn't know anything about the Mystic Realm." Xiao Hua said, surprising Yuan since she's usually the most knowledgeable.

"I know about it." Feng Yuxiang's voice quickly resounded, and she continued, "It's a very large event in the Lower Heavens that only occurs once every 10 years."

"It's an event where only the most powerful sects in the Lower Heavens can participate, and the results will determine the sects' rank for the next decade, so it's very important to these elite sects that care so much about their position."

"As for the participants in question, if you perform well and catch the attention of the judges, there's a very small chance that you'll be given the chance to become a disciple at one of the sects that exist in the upper heaven— Spirit Heaven."

"Wait a second... Does this mean the judges for this Mystic Realm are people from the upper heavens?" Yuan asked.

"That's right. The Mystic Realm is organized by 7 different sects from the upper heavens. It's a tradition that has existed since ancient times." Feng Yuxiang said.

"I see... Anything else?"

"Let's talk about the Mystic Realm itself. From what I heard, the Mystic Realm is actually a world of its own, meaning it doesn't belong to any of the heavens," said Feng Yuxiang.

"Anyways, while I haven't been to the Mystic Realm myself, I have heard plenty of stories about it. Inside the Mystic Realm, your cultivation base is wiped, so it's almost like you're starting from scratch in a sense."

"Inside the Mystic Realm, you can earn points by increasing your cultivation level or defeating magical beasts, and you can even earn points by helping people. Almost everything you do is judged."

"I see..." Yuan mumbled.

"Therefore, even if the Young Master reaches Spirit Master, it won't matter once you're inside the Mystic Realm."

"I know, but I still want to reach Spirit Master since I am so close to it. Once I reach Spirit Master, I'll probably take a break from cultivating like

this since I don't like spending most of my time sitting still like this." Yuan sighed.

"Young Master, how close are you to your breakthrough?" Feng Yuxiang suddenly asked him, and she continued, "I have a monster core at the 6th level Spirit Warrior with me if you want to consume it..."

"Eh? Really? But I don't want to accept something so precious from you without giving you anything in return— even if you're my servant." Yuan said to her.

"How about the Young Master donates more blood to me in return for the monster core?" Feng Yuxiang said.

"Are you sure? I'll be giving you my blood regardless if you give me the monster core or not."

"I'm sure, Young Master. In fact, my body is craving for your blood even as we speak, and I am trying my best to hold it in. If giving you this monster core will allow me to drink your blood even a day sooner, I would not hesitate!"

After thinking about it for a moment, Yuan nodded his head and said, "Okay. I'll exchange my blood for your monster core."

After all, he was already getting tired of sitting still after just a few days of cultivation, and he hated remaining in one spot for long periods of time since it reminded him of the real world.

"Great!"

Feng Yuxiang appeared from his body after Yuan agreed to accept the monster core, and she retrieved a monster core from her spatial ring.

"This is a monster core?" Yuan raised his eyebrows at the glowing monster core that looked somewhat different from the monster cores he had eaten, as it had this fiery appearance.

"Did you forget who I was before I became your servant already, Young Master? I am the owner of one of the most prestigious shops in the Golden Phoenix Bazaar. I have no need for 'normal' treasures, and monster cores are no different." Feng Yuxiang said.

And she continued, "This monster core belongs to a Rainbow Koi, an incredibly rare magical beast that can only be found in one place within the Lower Heavens— the Frozen Cave, one of the very few danger zones in this world."

"Rainbow Kois are Spirit Warriors at birth, and they grow incredibly fast. However, they don't really have much combat prowess, if any at all, and they die naturally once they reach Spirit Master, so they have a short lifespan, and if they die naturally, it won't drop its monster core."

"This is why Rainbow Koi monster cores are considered a priceless treasure and are sought after by many. Furthermore, people who absorb them have a very small chance to obtain a special power that allows them to control fire, and it gives more spiritual energy than normal monster cores at its level."

Feng Yuxiang explained to him.

"Controlling fire? From a fish? How does that work?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"Well, one can control fire using their spiritual energy, but those with this power can control fire without needing spiritual energy, saving them a lot of energy. Furthermore, the monster core enhances one's ability towards fire techniques, so most people looking for them are all practitioners who use techniques related to fire, such as alchemy masters."

"I see... What a unique monster core. It's definitely different from what I've consumed in the past." Yuan mumbled as he accepted the monster core from Feng Yuxiang.

Chapter 275 - Spirit Master

"While it might not help you breakthrough to Spirit Master, it should close that distance by a lot." Feng Yuxiang said to Yuan as she handed him the fiery-looking monster core that looked as though there were living flames trapped inside.

"Wow... It's warm..." Yuan mumbled after feeling the heat the monster core was emitting on his palms.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan popped the Rainbow Koi's monster core into his mouth, and unlike normal monster cores that only had a sweet taste, the Rainbow Koi's monster core actually tasted somewhat spicy after the sweetness!

[Heaven Refining Physique activated]

[1,325,888,196 Qi has been refined from the Rainbow Koi's monster core]

19,691,520,000/19,691,520,000

[You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough]

[Because your Qi Experience is already full, you will not be able to receive anymore Qi until you reach the next realm]

[You have met the requirements for a breakthrough]

[You have reached First Level Spirit Master]

[+10,000 stats]

[Your 'Advanced Senses' has developed into 'Superior Senses']

[Superior Senses]

[Rank: Earth]

[Description: Greatly enhances the functions of all available senses permanently. Requires no activation]

[Heaven Refining Physique activated]

The physique suddenly activated again.

[You have gained 'Novice Fire Control', 'Weak Fire Enhancement', and 'Weak Fire Resistance' from consuming the Rainbow Koi's monster core]

[Novice Fire Control]

[Description: Allows you to control fire elements without using spiritual energy]

[Weak Fire Enhancement]

[Description: Enhances all fire techniques' strength by 50%. No activation required.]

[Weak Fire Resistance]

[Description: Slightly increases your fire resistance. No activation required.]

"Oh, I had a breakthrough. I'm now a Spirit Master." Yuan looked at his hands with a slightly dazed look on his face, feeling his body overwhelming with energy and strength.

"W-What?!" Feng Yuxiang stared at Yuan with a gawking look on her face, as she didn't expect him to suddenly breakthrough, much less a breakthrough without any enlightenment!

Not even in her wildest dream could she have imagined that Yuan would reach Spirit Master without needing any enlightenment!

This kind of talent was simply too terrifying! It shouldn't exist if she has to be honest!

"So Brother Yuan didn't need enlightenment to reach Spirit Master, either, huh? Just where is Brother Yuan's limit if he even has one?" Xiao Hua's defeated voice suddenly resounded, sounding like she was already used to it.

"What do you mean by that?" Feng Yuxiang asked her.

"Brother Yuan also entered Spirit Warrior without any enlightenment; it was just like any other normal breakthrough for him." Xiao Hua said.

"Unbelievable..." Feng Yuxiang mumbled in a dazed voice, and she continued, "Just what is your body made of, Young Master?"

"Even if you ask me that, how am I supposed to answer that kind of question?" Yuan responded with a bittersweet smile on his face.

The most logical explanation would be the game's system that's allowing him to breakthrough without needing any enlightenment. Another reason that could be causing this would be his unknown bloodline.

Yuan summoned his status and looked at it—

Cultivation: First Level Spirit Master

Legacy: None

Bloodline: None

Physique: Heaven Refining Physique

Physical Strength: 39,734

Mental Strength: 39,975

Soul Strength: 51,410

Physical Defense: 39,710

Mental Defense: 40,821

Qi Experience: ???/???

'Huh? Why does my Qi Experience have so many question marks? Is the number so big that even the game is having trouble calculating it?' Yuan wondered to himself after seeing it. How will he see how much Qi he needs for the next level now?

Sometime later, Yuan said, "Anyways, now that I am a Spirit Master, I no longer need to continue cultivating, so I'll just leave this place and find something else to do until the Mystic Realm."

"Young Master, what about the fire controlling skill? Did you manage to obtain it after consuming the monster core?" Feng Yuxiang suddenly asked him.

Yuan nodded and said, "Yes, I got it."

"..."

Feng Yuxiang didn't show much of a reaction after learning that Yuan had managed to overcome the small chance and obtain the ability to control fire without using his spiritual energy, mostly because she was still numb from her previous shock.

"I'm going to tell Elder Xuan that I'm done here," Yuan said before retrieving the communication jade slip and calling Elder Xuan.

"What's the matter, Disciple Yuan?" Elder Xuan picked up a couple of moments later than usual.

"Senior Xuan, I just had a breakthrough and reached Spirit Master. What should I do now?" Yuan asked him.

"..."

However, Elder Xuan did not respond even a good minute later, making Yuan wonder if Elder Xuan was still there.

"Elder Xuan? Did you hear me?"

"Huh?! What did you just say? I'm sorry, but I don't think I heard you correctly just now. Did you say that you'd reached Spirit Master?" Elder Xuan finally responded, his voice filled with disbelief.

"Yes, that's right. I've just reached Spirit Master." Yuan repeated.

"..."

After another moment of silence, Elder Xuan spoke loudly, but he wasn't talking to Yuan—

"Sect Master! H-He did it! He reached Spirit Master!"

"What?! Is that true?!" Long Yijun's shocked voice, which was also filled with excitement, quickly responded.

"Yes! I am speaking to him right now!" Elder Xuan said.

"Hahaha! This is great! Bring him here!" Long Yijun then said.

"Yes, Sect Master!" Elder Xuan said before returning to Yuan, "Stay right there. I'll be there in a few to pick you up. The Sect Master would like to speak with you."

"Okay," Yuan said before closing the connection.

Meanwhile, at the sect master's headquarters, after Elder Xuan left the place, Long Yijun looked at Gao Dongya and Xue Jiye and said to them with a smile on his face, "Looks like you'll meet him sooner than expected."

Gao Dongya swallowed nervously.

'I heard them talking about reaching Spirit Master... Don't tell me...' he wondered inwardly.

Meanwhile, Xue Jiye had another thought in her mind, 'Is it him? Could it really be him? That genius during the disciple examination?'

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Chapter 276 - Introducing The Team

A few minutes after he spoke with Elder Xuan through the communication jade slip, Yuan could see a cloud in the distance approaching his location.

A few more moments later, this cloud landed in front of Yuan with Elder Xuan standing on top of it.

"First and foremost, allow me to congratulate you on your breakthrough, Disciple Yuan. You don't see an 18-year-old Spirit Master every day if ever." Elder Xuan said with a warm smile on his face, looking like a grandfather watching his grandchildren grow up.

"Thank you, Elder Xuan," Yuan said.

"Come with me. I will take you to the Sect Master where you'll meet the other two disciples that will be participating in the Mystic Realm with you."

Yuan nodded and stepped onto the flying treasure before they soared to the sect master's headquarters.

They landed a few minutes later, and they walked into the building.

"It's really you! I knew it!" Xue Jiye shouted in a surprised voice the moment she saw Yuan's black jade mask, even pointing at him with a trembling finger.

Yuan turned to look at Xue Jiye, and he mumbled, "Oh, you're the girl who accidentally leaked herself during—"

"H-Hey! Why are you bringing that up?!" Xue Jiye quickly interrupted him in a panicked manner, and she continued with a flushed face, "And that was entirely your fault! If you hadn't looked at me with those eyes, none of that would've happened!"

"Oh, right. The two of you have already met." Elder Xuan remembered that Xue Jiye was the one watching over Yuan during the Tablet of Comprehension exam.

"Disciple Yuan, congratulations on reaching Spirit Master so quickly. Once again, you have exceeded my expectations." Long Yijun suddenly said to him, shocking Gao Dongya and Xue Jiye who only noticed his immense aura after the mention.

'Heavens! How long has it been since I last saw him when he was only at the fifth level of Spirit Warrior?!' Xue Jiye cried inwardly after seeing Yuan's overwhelming growth.

Meanwhile, Gao Dongya stood in the background with an unreadable expression on his face.

"Come over here, Disciple Yuan, so I can introduce you to these two who will be participating in the Mystic Realm with you." Long Yijun said.

Yuan nodded his head and went to stand beside Long Yijun, who patted his shoulders and said, "This is Disciple Yuan, a disciple who recently joined the Dragon Essence Temple. And before you question his qualifications, allow me to tell you some of his achievements."

Long Yijun cleared his throat before speaking in a manner that sounded like he was bragging about his own son in public, "Disciple Yuan has not only managed to take 100 steps during the third test at the silver pond but he'd also managed to achieve 100 percent comprehension at the final exam with the Tablet of Comprehension."

"What! 100 steps in the silver pond?!" Xue Jiye exclaimed.

However, Long Yijun wasn't finished, and he continued in an even prouder-sounding voice, "That's not all! Do you remember what happened recently at the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower?"

"Impossible... You don't mean he's..." Gao Dongya couldn't help but open his mouth after hearing this obvious hint.

"That's right! Disciple Yuan was the one who cleared all 100 floors, becoming the first person in the sect's history to achieve such a feat!"

Gao Dongya and Xue Jiye swallowed nervously upon hearing this, and they recall the rumors that had been spreading around the sect regarding the challenge on the 100th floor.

They slowly turned to look at Yuan and his clear eyes that glistened brightly behind his black mask.

"Now introduce yourselves." Long Yijun asked the two disciples.

Xue Jiye nodded and went first, "Even though we have already met before, allow me to introduce myself again. I am Xue Jiye, currently 20 years old, and I specialize in dagger techniques."

"Oh?" Yuan raised his eyebrows after learning that Xue Jiye also uses daggers, taking him by surprise.

After Xue Jiye's introduction, the handsome young man standing beside her said in a calm voice, "Gao Dongya, 25 years old, and I'm a swordmaster."

"Now that you know each other, I want you three to familiarize yourselves with each other before the Mystic Realm, as you are required to work in a team inside." Long Yijun said to them.

And then he continued, "Do any of you have any questions for me?"

Yuan quickly raised his hands and spoke, "When is the Mystic Realm?"

Long Yijun quickly replied, "The Mystic Realm will happen in four days, but we will leave the sect 2 days before that since the place is very far from

our current location, so you all have two days to prepare yourselves."

"Of course, since the Mystic Realm doesn't allow you to bring any treasures with you inside, you shouldn't need any luggage, to begin with," he continued.

"I would tell you more about the Mystic Realm but there have been rumors about the Mystic Realm being somewhat different from the previous years — that something big has happened in the upper heavens, so I can only tell you what the previous Mystic Realms have been like."

Thus, Long Yijun proceeded to tell them about the experiences the previous disciples had experienced inside the Mystic Realm.

By the time Long Yijun was finished, many hours had passed with half of the day already done.

"Anyways, this is all I know about the Mystic Realm. It may or may not be helpful information." Long Yijun said to them, and he continued, "I will contact you again in two days when we leave or when I need you again."

Sometime later, Yuan and the other two disciples left the sect master's headquarters.

"Hey, how about we go eat something at the Dragon Pavilion? My treat." Xue Jiye suddenly said shortly after they left, her gaze directly on Yuan as she spoke, almost like there was a deeper meaning behind her words.

"I'll pass." Gao Dongya didn't hesitate to refuse before walking away.

Chapter 277 - Xue Jiye

"What an unfriendly fellow, even though the Sect Master just told us to connect with each other. Oh well, at least I won't be using more contribution points." Xue Jiye said as she walked. Gao Dongya walked away.

A few seconds later, Xue Jiye returned to Yuan and asked him again, "What about you? Want to come?"

Yuan nodded his head, "I will go with you."

There was no way he'd refuse food, especially if it was free. Of course, he also wanted to know a little bit more about the disciples that will be participating in the Mystic Realm with him.

"Great. Then let's go."

Xue Jiye began walking shortly later, and she thought to herself, 'Unless he plans on eating with that mask on, I will finally be able to see the face behind that mask!'

The two of them arrived at the Dragon Pavilion sometime later, and they were taken to the best seat in the place.

Once they were seated, Xue Jiye said, "Go ahead. Order whatever you want. I'll pay for it."

Yuan nodded his head and proceeded to pick every item on the menu, shocking the waitress there and Xue Jiye, who stared at him with wide eyes.

Despite being a Core Disciple and unlike Fei Yuyan, Xue Jiye did not have many contribution points to spare since she would use them to exchange for

treasures to power up, and she didn't expect Yuan to order that much food, putting her in a difficult spot.

"You... Can you really eat all of that? Or are you just messing with me?" Xue Jiye asked him after the waitress went away to get the order.

"Why would I mess with you? Of course, I can eat all of them. Why else would I order them?" Yuan quickly responded.

"..."

Xue Jiye was left speechless by his serious voice.

After a moment of silence, she said, changing the topics, "Anyways, how long has it been since you joined the sect? A month?"

Yuan nodded and said, "About."

"What have you been doing since then? Well, besides challenging the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower and becoming the first person to have cleared all 100 floors?"

Yuan had to think a little before he responded. And after thinking for a minute, Yuan realized that he didn't really do much in the sect besides the Zither Competition and participating in a match.

"Well, I participated in a music competition and I fought another disciple on the stage," he finally said.

"You fought another disciple? Who would dare to fight you?" Xue Jiye seemed more surprised that anyone would fight a genius like him than anything.

"Someone named Wu Laohu, I think."

"Wu Laohu? Never heard of him." Xue Jiye shrugged.

As a Core Disciple, they usually don't pay attention to matters outside of the Inner Court, so while Wu Laohu was quite famous within the Outer

Court, he was essentially a nobody in the Inner Court.

Sometime later, the waitress returned with the food.

"Well... go on. I'd like to see you eat all of them." Xue Jiye said to him, anticipating to see Yuan remove his mask.

Yuan nodded, and as Xue Jiye had expected, he removed his black jade mask so he could eat properly.

"So young!" Xue Jiye's jaw dropped upon seeing Yuan's young and handsome face. "H-How old are you again?"

"Me? I'm 18 years old." Yuan casually responded.

"Eighteen?!"

Xue Jiye cannot imagine being 18 years old and a Spirit Master at the same time. What kind of talent would that take?

If only Xue Jiye knew that Yuan had only started cultivating recently. Who knows how she—or anyone in this world would react if they knew.

While Xue Jiye stared at him silently, Yuan went to eat his food before it turned cold, quickly consuming everything on the table.

'Did my capacity increase after becoming a Spirit Master?' Yuan wondered inwardly after realizing that he was not full despite eating so much food that would normally give him a full belly.

Meanwhile, Xue Jiye was full after a single dish.

"Thank you for this meal, Disciple Xue," Yuan said to her after wiping his lips with a warm towel.

"D-Don't even mention it..." she responded in a defeated voice.

After paying the bill with what felt like a bleeding heart, Xue Jiye said, "I guess I will see you in two days when the Mystic Realm begins."

Yuan nodded, "See you later."

By the time they left the Dragon Pavilion, the sky was already beginning to darken.

Yuan went straight home, where he tested the effects of becoming a Spirit Master.

The first he did was test his Divine Sense, and to his surprise, the area of effect for his Divine Sense more than doubled, perhaps even tripling compared to before, allowing him to see even Min Li's house—the entirety of it.

"Wow... I can see so many things at once..." Yuan mumbled in a voice of awe.

"Just wait until you're a Spirit Grandmaster or higher, Young Master. In the upper heavens, there are people who can cover even an entire city with their Divine Sense." Feng Yuxiang said to him.

"Un." Yuan nodded.

After familiarizing himself with his new profound strength, Yuan logged off for the day to test out his Divine Sense in the real world, but alas, he was still unable to fully release his Divine Sense.

"Welcome back, Meixiu," Yuan said to her after she returned from school.

"I'm back, Yuan."

"You don't have school tomorrow, right?"

"That's right," Meixiu said.

"Then would you like to play with me tomorrow? The Mystic Realm is in a few days, and I would like to hand the Divine-grade treasure to you so that you can sell it." Yuan said to her.

"I promised the Young Lady that I would visit her tomorrow morning, but I will play the game once I return," Meixiu said.

"Okay."

Meixiu went to prepare dinner later, and Yuan cultivated while he waited. Sometime later, Meixiu returned to the room with dinner.

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Chapter 278 - Visiting Yu Rou

After feeding Yuan, Meixiu went to do her own things until she went to sleep.

Meanwhile, Yuan stayed up all night to cultivate like usual.

'I don't even remember when was the last time I got two nights of sleep in a row...' Yuan thought to himself, but oddly enough, he didn't feel any different despite lacking sleep. In fact, he felt more refreshed and energetic than ever.

The following morning, after feeding Yuan breakfast, Meixiu returned to the main house to meet with Yu Rou.

"Hey, Meixiu. Even though we saw each other at school yesterday, it feels longer than that." Yu Rou said to her.

However, Meixiu didn't immediately respond, and she looked around the room with raised eyebrows.

After a moment of silence, she spoke, "Young Lady, when was the last time you cleaned your room? It's a mess in here."

"You're exaggerating, Meixiu." Yu Rou casually said.

Meixiu turned to look at the clothes laying on the floor as well as the dirty desk in the distance.

Normally, Meixiu would be the one who cleans Yu Rou's room daily, but since she no longer lives here and spends most of her time with Yuan, that has become impossible.

"Young Lady... did you even find someone to replace me?" Meixiu suspected that nobody was taking care of Yu Rou in her place because no servant would dare to allow such an unkempt appearance in her room.

"..."

After a moment of silence, Yu Rou spoke, "I didn't find a replacement for you."

"What? Why?" Meixiu asked her in a genuinely surprised voice.

"Think about it, Meixiu. If I replaced you, my parents would know that you're currently taking care of Brother Tian, and there's a good chance that they'll tell you not to help him. Therefore, I cannot replace you no matter what." Yu Rou gave Meixiu an explanation on why she didn't find another servant.

"Oh..." Upon realizing the situation, Meixiu nodded her head.

"However, that doesn't excuse your messy room, Young Lady. I am going to clean up now." Meixiu said, and she immediately went to tidy up the room.

Seeing this, Yu Rou said with a smile on her face, "I didn't want to take any more of your job away from you, so I purposefully refused to clean my room so you can do it."

"..." Meixiu was speechless. Does Yu Rou intend on leaving her room dirty for an entire week just so she could clean it for her? That's unbefitting of her image.

"What about the other things? Who will take care of you?" Meixiu then asked her.

"I don't need anybody to take care of me. I have been taking care of brother Tian while taking care of myself for many years now— as if I need someone to do everything for me. And I don't trust anybody else to be so close in my life. They'll definitely tell my parents about everything I do."

"By the way, speaking of Brother Tian, how's he doing recently? Did anything significant happen?"

"Not that I know of." Meixiu shook her head as she folded Yu Rou's clothes.

"Oh, I see. Oh, when you go back, can you tell Brother Tian that players who have been approaching the Dragon Essence Temple are being beaten by the disciples of that sect so they cannot approach the place? Though, I think he should still try to hide his identity since we can never be too careful."

Meixiu looked at her with a still face before speaking, "Young Lady... Wouldn't it be better if you spoke to him yourself?"

Yu Rou immediately frowned and said, "And how am I supposed to do that, Meixiu? I cannot even meet with Brother Tian! While I can sneak a meeting with him, I shouldn't do something so risky when everything is still heated regarding Brother Tian's situation."

"But you don't need to see the Young Master to speak with him, Young Lady. You can always call him. There's no way the Masters would find out that way." Meixiu said.

"Eh?"

Yu Rou immediately turned dead silent, and she stared at Meixiu with a shocked expression on her face, looking like she'd just realized something.

"W-Why didn't I think of that before?! My brain must have stopped working after being told that I could no longer meet with Brother Tian! I totally forgot about this method!" Yu Rou exclaimed a moment later.

"Thank you for reminding me! Ah! But Brother Tian doesn't have a phone. Meixiu, since you'll be with Brother Tian whenever I can call him, I'll just call your phone and speak with Brother Tian that way!" Yu Rou then said.

Meixiu nodded, "I understand."

"I'll call you later tonight after dinner, so make sure you're free by then!"

After cleaning Yu Rou's room, Meixiu went to work outside a little just so the other servants won't be suspicious of her disappearance.

"Isn't that Meixiu? Hey, Meixiu! Where have you been lately? It feels like forever since I last saw you!" One of the other servants called her out after noticing her.

Meixiu stopped sweeping the floor and turned to look at the middle-aged woman that was approaching her, and she spoke with a nonchalant look on her face, "The Young Lady has assigned me with a project so I spend most of my time outside now."

The middle-aged lady nodded and said, "It must be hard being the only person working for the Young Lady. However, it's definitely much better than working for that crippled thing. I cannot imagine being near him, much less taking care of him every day. I'm glad the Masters finally got rid of him; it was long overdue. The Young Lady can also finally focus on her school and music without wasting her time on that thing."

"..."

Meixiu's grip on the broom subtly tightened when she heard the other servant's words, but she didn't say anything and remained silent. Hell, even her nonchalant expression remained still, acting like she wasn't affected by the other servant's clear disdain for Yuan.

Chapter 279 - Housekeeper

"By the way, if you're still cleaning, you should hurry up. The housekeeper, your mother, she'll be here to visit us in half an hour." The other servant said to her before walking away in a nonchalant manner.

"Mother, huh..." Meixiu mumbled in a low voice.

Indeed, visiting Yu Rou wasn't the only reason she returned today, as her mother, the head of the servants, was visiting today as well.

Ten minutes later, after cleaning up the area outside of Yu Rou's room, Meixiu went to the courtyard where many other servants were already gathered.

There were about a dozen servants working at the house, and all of them were already standing in an orderly fashion in a straight line.

"It's been a while since the Housekeeper visited us, and whenever she does, it's because something bad has happened."

"Not always. Sometimes she visits us to make sure things are in an orderly fashion. Of course, if she finds even the slightest mistakes, we'll get yelled at— and that happens every single time she visits."

Even though the Housekeeper had yet to arrive, these maids didn't dare to speak loudly, and they all mumbled to each other.

Meixiu ignored them and went to stand in the formation.

The other servants went silent for a moment when they noticed Meixiu. Out of all of the servants there, she was the youngest and most definitely the prettiest. Furthermore, Meixiu worked directly with Yu Rou, the Young

Lady, making her position above theirs automatically. This would, of course, cause some people to be jealous of her. However, knowing who Meixiu's mother was, they didn't dare to badmouth her, as they feared the Housekeeper more than the Masters themselves.

A few minutes later, much earlier than expected, a figure could be seen approaching them from a distance; it was a tall and pretty woman with black hair tied into a large bun behind her head, and she had a cold and serious expression on her face.

At glance, one could see similarities between her and Meixiu, such as their naturally nonchalant facial features and their somewhat distant aura.

When the servants saw this woman's figure, they immediately straightened their bodies and faces.

Once the Housekeeper stopped walking and stood a few meters in front of the formation, the servants all bowed and greeted her simultaneously, "Good morning, Senior Housekeeper!"

The Housekeeper didn't respond to their greetings and proceeded to walk and stand in front of the servant that was to the very right of the formation.

Once the Housekeeper stopped walking, the servant lifted her head and stood there like a statue.

The Housekeeper proceeded to inspect the servant's uniform and her appearance overall.

"Turn."

The servant turned her body around at the Housekeeper's command.

"Turn."

A few moments later, the servant turned around, facing the Housekeeper again.

"Your collar is crooked, there's a strand of hair on your shoulder, and your shoes are dusty. Since when did we hire monkeys to work for the Yu Family? Get out of my sight and fix yourself right now." The Housekeeper said to the servant in a cold voice.

"Yes, Housekeeper!" The servant didn't dare to complain despite being called a monkey, and she quickly left the scene.

Once she finished inspecting the first servant, the Housekeeper went to stand in front of the next servant and began inspecting her as well.

The Housekeeper continued to inspect the servants until all of them were checked.

"Turn."

Meixiu turned around in a smooth and graceful movement.

"Turn."

Meixiu turned around again.

"..."

The Housekeeper silently stared at Meixiu for a moment before turning around and walking back to her original spot without saying a word.

By the time the Housekeeper finished her inspection, the servants that were told to leave have returned with their appearances corrected.

Once everyone was back, the Housekeeper said, "It appears that most of you have gotten complacent since my last visit, hence your disgraceful appearances. If I spot even a single mistake during my next visit which will be unannounced, I will have everyone here retake their maid training. Of course, you can refuse, but that will be the end of your career in the Yu Family."

The servants there trembled after hearing the Housekeeper's words.

A few moments later, the Housekeeper continued, "I will walk around the house in a moment to make sure you're not slacking on cleaning the household, either."

The Housekeeper dismissed the servants a moment later, telling them to go back to work.

However, just as Meixiu began walking, she was stopped.

"You stay right here, Meixiu."

"Yes, Housekeeper," Meixiu responded before standing there in silence.

Once all of the other servants disappeared, the Housekeeper approached Meixiu and said, "You don't seem any different than usual despite the situation."

"I don't understand what you're trying to tell me, Housekeeper," Meixiu said.

"You can drop the act with me, little girl. The Young Master was disowned and you're telling me that you don't feel anything?" The Housekeeper said to her.

"Is that why you visited today... Mother?" Meixiu asked her.

"Yes, because I wanted to see your crying face, but it appears to me that you're not the least worried or saddened that he is no longer in your life. And to think that you used to motivate yourself using the Young Master whenever you were having difficulties during training."

Meixiu's eyebrows twitched upon hearing her mother's words.

And her mother continued, "Or did you forget about it? If you forgot your purpose— why you became a servant in the first place, allow me to help you remember. You were originally trained to become the Young Master's personal servant and more. The reason you even managed to endure the hellish training at such a young age was because you wanted to be with him — by the Young Master's side."

"You don't have to remind me because I remember it very well, mother,"
Meixiu said after a moment of silence.

"Really? Because it doesn't look that way." Her mother stared at her with a
mysterious glint in her eyes.

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Chapter 280 - Meixius Mother

Chapter 280 - Meixiu's Mother

"Why do you even care, anyways? You usually don't talk about him. Furthermore, the Young Master is gone and there's nothing you nor I can do about it." Meixiu said when her mother continued glaring at her like she did something wrong.

"Do you really not care about the Young Master? Did your feelings for him change after he became a cripple? I guess you're no different from the other maids— always filled with disdain towards him and forgetting who he used to be." Her mother shook her head.

Meixiu gritted her teeth after hearing her mother's words before shouting in a loud voice, "Don't compare me to those trash!"

"..."

Her mother remained a calm expression despite Meixiu's unexpected outburst— or maybe because she expected Meixiu's outburst that she didn't react. Regardless, she has always managed to break Meixiu's nonchalant appearance with ease.

"I see." Her mother said in a nonchalant voice before turning around and walking away.

"Follow me," she suddenly said.

Meixiu didn't say anything and followed her mother inside the house.

A few minutes later, they arrived in front of Yu Rou's room, something Meixiu expected when she saw the direction they were walking in.

Meixiu's mother knocked on the doors immediately after they arrived, and she proceeded to stand in front of the doors in a manner that reeked of professionalism.

Meanwhile, Meixiu stood beside her in a similar fashion.

A few moments later, Yu Rou opened the doors.

"Greetings, Young Lady."

Meixiu's mother bowed to Yu Rou and greeted her. Meixiu followed despite already meeting with Yu Rou before this.

"Hello, Miss Meifeng. It's been a while." Yu Rou returned the greeting in a graceful manner.

"May I come inside for a moment?" Meifeng asked her.

"Of course." Yu Rou nodded.

Meixiu and her mother, Meifeng, entered Yu Rou's room a moment later.

Upon entering the room, Meifeng immediately started looking around the room with her sharp gaze, clearly looking to see if the room was clean.

"Don't worry, Miss Meifeng. Meixiu has been doing her job flawlessly." Yu Rou said with a smile on her face.

"I just wanted to make sure that my daughter hasn't been slacking on her work." Meifeng nodded her head, yet she still continued to inspect Yu Rou's room for another minute afterward, even wiping uncommon areas behind Yu Rou's desk with her fingers to see if there was any dust.

"Anyways, why did you come here today, Miss Meifeng?" Yu Rou asked her as she took a seat on the bed.

Meifeng then said, "I just wanted to make sure you were doing fine, Young Lady. Even though I work at the main household now, I used to be your

caretaker. Is it weird for me to come by once in a while to see your condition?"

Yu Rou showed a bittersweet smile before speaking, "As expected, you're here because of my brother's situation."

"I'm sorry you had to go through this, Young Lady. Don't tell the Masters I said this, but I really don't think the Young Master deserved to be disowned. Even though he's still so young, he'd already worked enough and deserves to rest for the rest of his life."

Meifeng's words dumbfounded Meixiu. In her mind, there was no way her mother could show such compassion— at least she has never seen it before.

"If there's anything I can do for you, please let me know."

Yu Rou nodded, "Thank you, Miss Meifeng, but I am fine."

After a moment of silence, Meifeng suddenly asked, "The Young Master... where is he right now? I cannot imagine leaving someone in his condition in the street and without a place to stay. Furthermore, his caretaker... Who's currently taking care of him?"

"That's..." Yu Rou immediately hesitated on responding.

Seeing this, Meifeng continued, "I know you're hesitant about telling me anything, and rightfully so. However, I am truly worried about the Young Master's wellbeing. You may not know this, but I was the Young Master's personal caretaker at one point."

"Eh? Really?" Yu Rou's eyes widened at Meifeng's words.

Meixiu was also surprised to hear this since she doesn't remember seeing her mother assist Yuan before.

"I was only assigned to him for a very brief moment, but during that short time, I've come to adore the Young Master and his talents that took the world by storm. I wanted to continue being his caretaker so I can personally witness his growth as a prodigy, but there were too many other things that

needed my attention, so I was eventually reassigned by the Masters." Meifeng said with a disheartened look on her face, her voice sincere.

However, before Yu Rou could even respond, Meifeng continued, "I'm sure the Young Master has a place to stay now, but that's not what I'm worried about. I am worried about his caretaker more than anything else."

"In fact, I have someone in mind. If you allow me, I will have that person take care of the Young Master."

"That's a bit..." Yu Rou didn't know how she should respond, and her eyes subconsciously turned to look at Meixiu for help.

"..."

As the head of all servants who could spot dust even from across the room, there was no way Meifeng could've missed the obvious shift in Yu Rou's eyes.

"I see... It's no wonder why I don't feel any sadness coming from you, Meixiu." Meifeng slowly turned around to look at her daughter with a narrowed gaze, and she continued in a slow but clear voice, "It's because you were never separated to begin with. You are the Young Master's new caretaker, am I right?"

Meixiu swallowed nervously after hearing Meifeng's words that were right on the spot.

"Miss Meifeng... This is..." Yu Rou also began panicking. What if she tells Meixiu that she cannot take care of Yuan? What if she assigns another individual to be Yuan's caretaker?

"That's right, mother. I am currently taking care of the Young Master. Do you have a problem with that?" Meixiu responded, not even bothering to hide the fact.

Chapter 281 - Yellow Envelope

"Do I have a problem, you say? Since when did you obtain the courage to speak back to me in such a manner?" Meifeng narrowed her eyes at Meixiu.

"..."

However, Meixiu did not back down and continued to stare at her own mother with a serious expression on her face.

"Miss Meifeng..." Yu Rou called out to her with cold sweat running down her own back.

After a moment of awkward silence, Meifeng finally spoke with a slight smile on her face, "No, I don't have any problems. In fact, I was going to help you volunteer to be the Young Master's caretaker."

"Really?" Yu Rou was surprised by Meifeng's approval.

Meifeng nodded and said, "When I couldn't stay by the Young Master's side, I thought that I could perhaps have Meixiu stand by his side in my stead. That's why I suggested training her in the first place."

Meixiu's eyes widened with surprise. While she'd agreed to take the training of her own will, she didn't know of her mother's intentions until today, and it was quite shocking, to say the least.

"Are you not worried about my parents saying something, Miss Meifeng? I doubt they'll allow your daughter to take care of Brother Tian..." Yu Rou suddenly asked her.

"Yes, I am. Hence, why I will be giving you two choices now, Meixiu." Meifeng said, and she stared at Meixiu dead in the eyes with a serious

expression.

"One, you will remain in the Yu Family and continue serving the Young Lady as her servant. However, you are not allowed to take care of the Young Master, as there is no way the Masters would allow you to do that."

"Or you can continue being the Young Master's caretaker. However, if you choose this path, you will have to leave the Yu Family and stop being the Young Lady's caretaker. It's either the Young Master or the Young Lady—you can't have both. Which will you pick?"

"..."

Meixiu's eyes widened with shock upon being given these two options.

However, to Meifeng and Meixiu's surprise, Yu Rou was the first to speak, and she said in a resolute voice, "Meixiu, you must pick Brother Tian! I can take care of myself, but Brother Tian... he cannot do that!"

"If I leave the Yu Family, what will happen to school...?" Meixiu suddenly asked.

"Of course, you will no longer be able to attend the same school as the Young Lady, as you're only there because of the Yu Family. However, if you're willing to pay the school fees by yourself, you'll still be able to attend the school like normal."

Meixiu frowned. Paying the school's fee by herself? Even with her savings, she won't last until the end of the year if she had to pay for such a prestigious school by herself.

"I know this is a difficult choice for you, but you cannot continue to sneak around. The Masters will eventually find out that you're helping the Young Master behind their backs, and the punishment for that will be much worse than just leaving the Yu Family. Hell, even my position may be at risk." Meifeng said.

And she continued, "If you choose to leave the Yu Family to take care of the Young Master, I'll also try to support you however I can. As for the Young Lady... I believe her when she says that she can take care of herself."

"Meixiu, do you even have to think about this?! You need to pick Brother Tian! As for your school, we'll think of something!" Yu Rou continued to urge her.

Meixiu suddenly closed her eyes, and memories of her childhood with Yuan quickly flowed into her head.

"What's wrong, Meixiu? Did you mess up again? Come here, you can cry on my shoulders..." Yuan's childish voice resounded in her head.

"Crying again? Here, do you want some chocolate? It'll make you feel better."

"Your training is almost done? Congratulations! Let's both do our best, okay?"

"..."

Meixiu opened her eyes after a long minute of silence before walking in front of Yu Rou.

After taking a deep breath, Meixiu lowered her body and bowed to Yu Rou, "I'm sorry, Young Lady, but I have decided to leave the Yu Family. Please forgive me."

A smile appeared on Yu Rou's face, and she nodded, "Thank you for your years of dedication and hard work, Meixiu. Please take care of Brother Tian from now on. I will definitely repay you in the future."

Sometime later, Meifeng said, "I will let the Masters know of your departure later, Meixiu."

She then turned to look at Yu Rou and continued, "Young Lady, if you don't mind, can I visit the Young Master? I haven't seen him in years..."

Yu Rou nodded and said, "Meixiu, you can bring Miss Meifeng to see Brother Tian when you leave. I'll have the other servants pack your things so you don't have to worry about that."

"Thank you, Young Lady."

"Don't call me that anymore, Meixiu. You're no longer working for me and I am no longer your Young Lady. Call me Sister Rou."

"That's... I understand, Sister Rou." Meixiu said to her after a slight hesitation, feeling a little bit odd afterward.

After talking with Yu Rou for a little bit longer, Meixiu left the place with Meifeng.

"..."

Once she was alone, Yu Rou laid on the bed with a dazed look on her face.

"Not just Brother Tian, even Meixiu is gone now... leaving me all alone in this place..." Even though she personally encouraged Meixiu to leave, Yu Rou couldn't help but shed some tears from Meixiu's departure.

After a moment of silence, she mumbled, "Maybe I should just leave this place and go with Brother Tian and Meixiu."

Yu Rou then got off the bed and walked to her desk. After unlocking one of the drawers with a key, Yu Rou used another key to unlock a box that was inside the drawers, retrieving a large yellow envelope that had a white label that read 'Certificate of Adoption'.

Yu Rou carefully opened the envelope that appeared to have already been opened before and stared at the certificate after taking it out, her expression as calm as a still pond.

After staring at the certificate and a certain name on it for a few moments, Yu Rou placed it back inside the envelope and locked her drawers before leaving her room with a gentle smile on her face.

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Chapter 282 - Apology

After leaving the house, Meixiu brought her mother to Yuan's apartment in a limousine. Of course, this limousine belonged to Meifeng despite her status as a servant, as she was only second in rank in the Yu Family, directly below Yu Rou and her parents.

"The Young Master is currently living in this apartment?" Meifeng raised her eyebrows upon arriving at the place.

While the apartment wasn't too bad, it wasn't fitting for someone like Yuan — at least that's what Meifeng thought.

In her mind, a genius like Yuan, someone who can literally make money rain with his god-like musical talents, doesn't deserve to live in an apartment with hundreds of other individuals.

Sometime later, they entered the elevator and quickly made their way to the 17th floor.

Klack.

Meixiu opened the door to 17F with her keys and said, "Young Master, I'm home."

Yuan, who was cultivating while waiting for Meixiu's return, was puzzled to hear the words 'Young Master' come out of her mouth when she seemed to have gotten used to calling him Yuan.

However, Yuan realized something was amiss when he heard two sets of footsteps entering the apartment.

'Did Yu Rou come? No... these footsteps are too gentle.' Yuan wondered to himself who this visitor could be if not Yu Rou.

"Young Master, you have a visitor," Meixiu said to him from outside his room after gently knocking on his doors.

"Who is it?" Yuan asked.

"Young Master, it's me." Meifeng quickly responded in an unbelievably soft voice.

"M-Miss Meifeng?!" Yuan immediately recognized her mature voice despite many years of not hearing it.

"May I come inside?" Meifeng asked him from outside.

"Y-Yes. Please, come inside."

Meifeng turned to look at Meixiu and said to her with a serious expression, "Stay out here. I want to speak with him privately."

Although she was hesitant to leave Yuan alone with her mother, she couldn't find the strength to refuse and nodded her head.

Meifeng approached the doorknob with her hands, and after taking a deep breath, she turned the handle and opened the door.

Upon entering Yuan's room and closing the door, Meifeng turned to look at the young man lying on the bed.

"Young Master..."

Meifeng was surprised to see Yuan's healthy complexion, but she didn't think too much about it for now and decided to kneel beside the bed on both her knees.

"Miss Meifeng, what are you doing here? Did..." Yuan was worried that his adopted parents might have found out about Meixiu helping him, hence why her mother was here.

"No, the Masters don't know about my presence here. You can relax. I am not here to separate Meixiu from you—I can't." As though she could see through his worries, Meifeng reassured him of his worries in a gentle voice.

"Then why are you...?"

"I'm here to apologize to you, dear Young Master..." Meifeng suddenly reached for one of Yuan's hands and held it close to her heart, treating it as though it was some kind of fragile treasure.

"Apologize? What for?" Yuan asked her in a truly puzzled voice.

"For everything..." Meifeng sighed, and she continued, "If I hadn't shown your musical talents to the Masters, they wouldn't have made you play for the family, and you would've kept your childhood at the very least for a few more years."

"However, because I showed the Masters your talents, they adopted you and essentially made you into a slave whose only purpose in life was to play music for the family, and it's entirely my fault that you had to sacrifice your childhood—yourself—with nothing in return."

"You earned the Yu Family countless fame and wealth, but what did you get in return? Not only did you lose your ability to see at a young age, but you also lost your ability to move shortly after. And now, a few years later, even the family that you supported and helped rise to the peak of the music world abandoned you..."

"Furthermore, I even stopped visiting you because of this guilt, as I could not bear seeing the Young Master in such a condition. I know that there's nothing I can say or do that will get rid of this sin, nor do I expect to be forgiven, but please, even if you hate me, do not blame Meixiu for any of this. She's an innocent girl who did her best at a very young age even if I scolded her a dozen times a day just so she could be by your side when I could not. If you have to hate someone, hate me, who brought you into the Yu Family."

Tears flowed from Meifeng's eyes as she cried in silence since she didn't want Yuan to realize that she was crying.

"..."

After a moment of silence, Yuan spoke in a soft voice, "Miss Meifeng, I don't blame you for any of this, much less hate you. There's no way I can hate you. After all, if not for you, I would've never met my sister Yu Rou, Meixiu, and many others. And even if you didn't tell the Yu Family about me, they would've still learned about me sooner or later since that video was widespread."

"While I do blame someone for this, it's definitely not you. As for my childhood... Even though I had spent most of it playing music for the Yu Family, I didn't see it just as 'playing for the Yu Family'. Yu Rou, Meixiu, you, and everyone who watched me perform... It's because of your smiles when I play the instruments that I play them."

"Fame? Wealth? I don't care about any of that."

"Young Master..."

The tears that had begun to stop suddenly started flowing again for Meifeng, and she began crying in a suppressed manner, as she was unable to resist her tears this time.

"Miss Meifeng, this may sound weird, but can you lay your head on my hand?" Yuan suddenly asked her.

Meifeng didn't think too much about it and followed his instructions, planting her cheeks on his warm hands.

Feeling the warmth of Meifeng's face on his palm, Yuan gritted his teeth and mustered all of his strength and cultivation to move his fingers that were closest to Meifeng's eyes, wiping some of the tears from her soaked eyes, shocking her greatly once she realized what had just happened.

"Y-Young Master... you... just now..." Meifeng lifted her head to stare at Yuan, who had a gentle smile on his face at this moment.

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Chapter 283 - The Perfect Solution

Hearing Meifeng's gasping voice, Yuan spoke with a smile on his face, "Even if my childhood was taken away from me, at least I still have my future, and I won't give up until I can personally leave this bed with my own strength."

"Young Master... you... are you really..." Meifeng almost couldn't believe what had just happened.

Did he just move his fingers? Even if it was just slightly, that is a huge improvement and a hopeful sign that he might actually recover in the future!

"Yes, I am really recovering. But please keep this a secret for now, as I want it to be a surprise for Meixiu and Yu Rou." Yuan said in a low voice.

"I will keep it a secret! I won't tell a single soul even if it's the last thing I do, I promise!" Meifeng nodded her head with excitement, causing the tears on her face to drop faster.

After spending a few minutes wiping her tears and calming down, Meifeng spoke, "Young Master, what do you plan on doing now that you're no longer part of the Yu Family? While you're definitely recovering, it's going to be difficult without the Yu Family's support and resources."

And she continued, "If you need money, just let me know and I'll do my best to support you."

"It's okay, Miss Meifeng. I already have a plan. However, I am worried about one thing."

"What are you worried about, Young Master? Is there anything I can do to help?"

"I don't know if you can help or not, but I am worried that Meixiu might get in trouble if the Yu Family learns that she's helping me, which might affect you as well, and I don't want that to happen. Do you know of any solutions?" Yuan asked her.

"I see..."

To Yuan's surprise, Meifeng actually began chuckling at his question, and he wondered if he'd said something funny.

"My dear Young Master, I have the perfect solution for that— one that won't cause any trouble for Meixiu even if the Masters find out," Meifeng said a moment later.

"Really?!" Yuan reacted with excitement. What could this solution possibly be? It sounded too good to be true!

"Yes, I would never lie to you, Young Master. Anyways, the solution to all of this is to have Meixiu leave the Yu Family, so even if she decides to work for you, they cannot complain about it." Meifeng said, immediately leaving Yuan speechless.

"M-Meixiu leaving the Yu Family? I don't think I can be that selfish— taking Meixiu away from Yu Rou. And what about Meixiu? What if she doesn't want to do that, and I won't force her either." Yuan quickly said.

"You don't have to worry about any of that, Young Master. In the first place, Meixiu was trained to become your caretaker, and lastly, she has already agreed to leave the Yu Family to be by your side." Meifeng finally revealed to him the situation.

"Wait... what? Meixiu decided to leave the Yu Family? What about Yu Rou?" Yuan mumbled in a shocked voice.

"Indeed, Meixiu has already left the Yu Family. I will be notifying the Masters later today. As for the Young Lady, she also agreed with this, even urging Meixiu to leave the family." Meifeng said.

"I... don't know what to say, really..." Yuan sighed, and he continued, "I just don't want to burden Meixiu any more than I already am..."

"A burden, huh?" Meifeng pondered for a moment before speaking again, "How about this, Young Master? Let's ask Meixiu what she thinks."

Meifeng then stood up from her kneeling position and took a moment to fix her appearance before going outside to call for Meixiu.

"Come here, Meixiu. The Young Master would like to speak with you." Meifeng said to her, who was standing near the entrance of the apartment.

Once they were inside Yuan's room together, Meifeng spoke, "Meixiu, the Young Master is worried that he might be a burden to you. Tell him the truth."

Meixiu nodded her head before speaking, "I enjoy taking care of the Young Master, and I do not see the Young Master as a burden."

"There you have it, Young Master. Meixiu herself has spoken. If you still doubt it, you're going to hurt Meixiu's feelings."

"I see..." Yuan mumbled in a somewhat dazed voice.

"Anyways, Meixiu will no longer be part of the Yu Family, and she will be your caretaker starting today." Meifeng said before turning to look at Meixiu, "As for school, if you wish to continue attending school, then I will try to work something out."

Meixiu nodded her head.

Once everything was settled, Meifeng looked at her watch and said, "I don't have much time left here, but before I leave, I need to make sure that you haven't forgotten your training and that you're taking care of the Young

Master properly. Therefore, you're going to show me how you take care of the Young Master right now."

"Right now? But what am I supposed to do? The Young Master already ate breakfast..."

Meifeng stood still for a moment before moving to wipe Yuan's forehead with her finger.

She then said, "Look, the Young Master is sweating. I want you to change his clothes, and while you're at it, wash his body."

Meixiu's eyes widened after hearing her mother's words. While she doesn't mind changing Yuan's clothes, washing Yuan's body in front of her mother is an entirely different story, especially if the last incident were to repeat itself.

"Why are you hesitating? If you're not going to take care of the Young Master properly, I won't hesitate to replace you."

Meixiu swallowed nervously, but she didn't dare to refuse her mother. Therefore, she could only nod her head.

Thus, Meixiu began removing Yuan's clothes whilst Meifeng stood in the background and silently watched her every movement.

This reminded Meixiu of her childhood when she was still in training, and just like currently, her mother would watch her from a distance, calling out on every minor mistake she makes.

Chapter 284 - Does It Feel Good?

"Meixiu, why are you removing the Young Master's clothes now?" Meifeng suddenly stopped Meixiu before she could even remove Yuan's shirt.

Seeing Meixiu's puzzled expression, Meifeng said in a strict voice, "Look around, do you see anything to carry the Young Master with? Or did you plan on letting the Young Master lie on the bed naked and wait until you're prepared? What if the Young Master catches a cold because of that?"

Meixiu's eyes widened after realizing her fault, and she immediately stopped removing Yuan's clothes to prepare the wheelchair.

"I apologize, Young Master," Meixiu said to him afterward.

"Don't worry about it, Meixiu," Yuan said.

However, Meifeng said, "The Young Master may forgive you, but I won't be as forgiving as your mother and trainer."

Sometime later, after she prepared the wheelchair, Meixiu picked up Yuan and carefully placed him onto the wheelchair while he was fully clothed.

Once Yuan was seated securely on the wheelchair, Meixiu pushed him into the bathroom, where she proceeded to remove Yuan's clothes.

"..."

Meifeng didn't say anything about this, but that's mostly because her attention was distracted by Yuan's refined body.

'How can someone who hasn't moved a muscle for so many years have such a refined body?' Meifeng wondered to herself.

While Meifeng stared at Yuan's naked body with a dazed look on her face, Meixiu turned on the water for the showerhead and began rinsing Yuan's body once she checked the temperature.

"Let me check the temperature as well." Meifeng suddenly said.

Meixiu nodded, handing the showerhead to her mother.

After feeling the temperature of the water for a moment, Meifeng handed the showerhead back to Meixiu without saying anything, which meant she has no complaints most of the time.

After rinsing Yuan's body, Meixiu squeezed some body wash onto a sponge and prepared to scrub Yuan's body.

However, Meifeng quickly stopped her and said, "Stop right there, Meixiu. What's that in your hands?"

"A sponge...?" Meixiu responded in a puzzled voice.

"And you plan on washing the Young Master's fragile body with a sponge? Use your hands!" Meifeng said to her.

Meixiu swallowed nervously before nodding her head and tossing the sponge to the side.

She began scrubbing Yuan's body with her bare hands shortly after, feeling surprised once she realized just how strong Yuan's body was.

A few minutes later, after washing Yuan's body and legs, Meixiu reached the area she feared the most, especially since her mother was still watching.

After swallowing nervously, Meixiu took a deep breath and began washing the final area with shaky hands.

Of course, Meifeng didn't miss this, but she remained silent.

"Hmm?" Meifeng raised her eyebrows when a certain something on Yuan raised as well.

'Since he can move his limbs to a certain extent, it's safe to assume that he can feel again as well, right?' Meifeng wondered to herself after seeing Yuan's wondrous reaction.

"Young Master, how are you feeling right now? Does it feel good?" Meifeng suddenly asked him, shocking Meixiu to the point where she stopped moving to stare at her with wide eyes.

"Eh? What do you mean by that, Miss Meifeng?" Yuan asked her in a genuinely puzzled voice.

"Hmm..." Meifeng narrowed her eyes and pondered, 'So it's just his body's natural reaction, huh? Or maybe he just doesn't understand it? Nobody taught him about that kind of stuff, after all.'

"Never mind, Young Master, it was just a misunderstanding," Meifeng said a moment later before looking at Meixiu.

"Why did you stop? Hurry up and continue washing the Young Master or he'll catch a cold," she continued.

Meixiu nodded her head with a dazed look on her face, and she continued washing Yuan's body.

"Slow down. What if you damage it? That area is worth more than you can possibly fathom, Meixiu." Meifeng said to Meixiu when she noticed Meixiu's rushing movements.

"I'm sorry," Meixiu said.

"Don't apologize to me. Apologize to the Young Master."

"I'm sorry, Young Master."

Yuan didn't know what they were talking about or why Meixiu was apologizing so he responded casually, "Don't worry about it."

After taking another minute to wash Yuan's precious area, Meixiu finally rinsed his soapy body with warm water before quickly drying him off with

a small towel.

A few moments later, they returned to Yuan's room.

Meixiu placed a blanket on the bed and placed Yuan on it before wiping the rest of his body.

Once Yuan was fully clean and dried, Meixiu helped Yuan into a new set of clothes.

However, just as Meixiu prepared to comb Yuan's hair with a brush, her mother interrupted and said, "I will brush the Young Master's hair."

Meixiu didn't refuse and passed the brush to her, and Meifeng began brushing Yuan's long hair gently and professionally.

"Thank you, Meixiu, Miss Meifeng. Words cannot describe my gratitude for your hard work." Yuan said to them afterward.

"Although we appreciate your feelings, we're not doing this for your gratitude, Young Master." Meifeng quickly responded.

"Even if that's the case, it won't change my feelings."

A few more minutes later, Meifeng's phone began ringing.

"It's my alarm, which means it's about time for me to leave. Although my visit today was shorter than I'd hoped, I will definitely return in the future to make sure everything is fine, Young Master." Meifeng said as she laid Yuan back onto the bed.

"Okay."

After Meifeng left the apartment and going downstairs to where her car was parked, Meifeng looked at Meixiu and said, "Meixiu, your dream... don't give up hope."

Meixiu's eyes immediately widened, and she asked in a mumbling voice, "W-What do you mean by that, mother?"

However, Meifeng dodged her question and said with a rare smile on her face, "Keep working hard and you'll definitely be rewarded in the future."

And before Meixiu could say anything else, Meifeng entered the car and closed the door before driving away.

After standing around for a few moments, Meixiu went back upstairs.

"Are you ready to play with me, Meixiu?" Yuan asked her after she returned.

"Just a minute, Young Master. I promised the Young Lady that I'd call her when I come back so she could talk to you." Meixiu said to him as she retrieved her phone and called Yu Rou.

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Chapter 285 - Phone Call

"Young Master? Miss Meifeng is no longer here. You can call me Yuan again." Yuan said to Meixiu.

"Oh, right..." Meixiu realized that she'd subconsciously reverted back to her old ways of addressing him after her mother's unexpected visit.

After calling Yu Rou's cell phone, Meixiu waited for her to answer.

One and a half rings later, Yu Rou picked up the phone and said, "Hello? Meixiu? Are you back at Brother Tian's place right now?"

"Yes, Young— Sister Rou. I am with him right now," Meixiu responded.

"Great! Can you pass the phone to him? You can even turn on the speaker."

Meixiu then turned on the speaker before placing the phone a few inches beside Yuan's head.

"Hello? Can you hear me?" Yu Rou's voice resounded on the speaker.

"I can hear you, Yu Rou," Yuan said.

"Phew! It feels like forever since I last heard your voice! And I'm sorry that I didn't call you early, Brother Tian. Even though I cannot see you, the thought of calling you never entered my mind for some reason."

"Don't worry about it."

"Is Miss Meifeng still there?"

"No, she just left."

"I see... Then I will assume that she'd already told you everything regarding Meixiu's situation."

"That's right. Miss Meifeng told me everything. But are you sure about this, Yu Rou? What about your caretaker? Will you be fine alone?"

"Are you underestimating me, brother? Did you forget that it was me who took care of you for the last couple of years? I think I can handle myself just fine!" Yu Rou said in a prideful voice.

"I guess you're right, Yu Rou. I'm sorry for doubting you. I just wanted to make sure."

"Don't worry about it. Anyways, I promised Xia Jingyi that I will play Cultivation Online in a bit so let's get to the topic."

After taking a deep breath, Yu Rou said, "Doctor Wang called me last night, and he said that he'll be visiting you later this afternoon. I gave him your address, so he should be there soon."

"Doctor Wang...? I understand." Yuan said.

"Next, let's talk about your bank account. I have created another bank account for you and Meixiu, so you'll both have access to it. As for the account that will be selling the items, I will send the information to Meixiu after this call."

"Meixiu, make sure you follow the instructions! Though, it's probably going to be impossible to completely hide Brother Tian's identity since he's selling a Divine-grade treasure, something only Player Yuan would have at this moment, especially when it's a zither and everybody knows that he'd participated in a zither competition."

"I understand," Meixiu said.

"Anyways, this is all I have for now. I'll call you tomorrow morning again, Brother Tian and Meixiu!" Yu Rou said to them before hanging up the phone.

"Now, let's—"

Just as Yuan opened his mouth to speak, Meixiu's cell phone began ringing again.

"Did you forget something?" Meixiu asked Yu Rou who called back for some reason.

"Right, I almost forgot to tell you that your stuff has been packed, and it will be shipped to your place tomorrow. Bye!" Yu Rou said before hanging up again.

"Anyways, what should we do now? I wanted to play with you when you returned, but Doctor Wang will be arriving soon." Yuan sighed.

"It's okay, Yuan. Now that I have left the Yu Family and school, I can stay home all day and play whenever you want." Meixiu said to him.

"Eh? You don't plan on going to school?" Yuan asked her in a surprised voice.

"I don't know yet, but I certainly don't have the funds to go to school since the Yu Family won't be supporting me once they learn of my leave."

"If it's money you need, once we sell the Divine-rank treasure, we should have more than enough to pay for your school!" Yuan said.

"The money from the game...?" Meixiu mumbled.

"Don't you want to go to school, Meixiu? You'll still get to see Yu Rou if you do." Yuan asked her.

After pondering for a moment, Meixiu said, "I... don't really want to go to school if I am being honest. It's a musical school filled with talented musicians but I can't even play a single instrument, making me feel out of place. And while there are classes not related to music, I learned these things years ago when I was a child. The only reason I went to school was because of Sister Rou."

"If you don't want to go to school, there is really nothing I can do. Since that's the case, let's play Cultivation Online together until you find something you want to do." Yuan said to her after a moment of silence.

"Okay." Meixiu nodded.

Half an hour later, Doctor Wang appeared before their doorsteps and knocked on the door.

"Oh, Meixiu. I guess this is the right place since you're here." Doctor Wang greeted her with a smile.

"May I come inside the apartment and see the Young Master?" Doctor Wang then asked.

Meixiu nodded.

"Young Master, how are you feeling?" Doctor Wang asked after entering his room.

"Doctor Wang, you can stop addressing me as Young Master now that I am no longer with the Yu Family," Yuan said to him.

"But I have been calling you 'Young Master' for almost ten years now. It's going to be awkward for me to suddenly change it."

"I guess whatever makes you feel more comfortable." Yuan then said.

"Thank you, Young Master. Anyways, I have heard about your situation from the Young Lady and I really don't know what to say..." Doctor Wang sighed, his gaze on Yuan a pitiful one.

"The Yu Family... what are they thinking, disowning their own son, not to mention the condition you're in... I have been speechless ever since I learned about it. When I told my granddaughter about it, she even bawled her eyes out for an hour straight." Doctor Wang shook his head.

After all, what kind of parents would throw away their disabled son out like trash because he didn't want to work for them?

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Chapter 286 - Minimal Price

"Don't worry, Young Master. Even if the Yu Family abandoned you, I will never abandon my patients." Doctor Wang said in a sincere voice.

"Thank you, Doctor Wang, but just your feelings are enough," Yuan said to him after hearing his words.

"Young Master, you do not have a choice in this. I had sworn to myself many years ago that I will never leave my patients' side until they're healed or take their very last breath trying." Doctor Wang said in a stern voice.

And he continued, "Even though I won't get a penny out of the Yu Family by doing this, it has never been about the money. I— your fans— we all want to see your recovery and await the day you can stand on the stage again with an instrument by your side. Of course, now that you are no longer with the Yu Family, you won't need to play the instrument. However, I still hope for that day."

"I..." Yuan opened his mouth but realized he was left speechless by Doctor Wang's words.

"You don't have to say anything, Young Master. Furthermore, I will still do your monthly check-up at the hospital like always and you won't have to pay a single penny for it." Doctor Wang said.

"No, I cannot let you do that, Doctor Wang. I will pay you for the treatments." Yuan quickly said.

"No offense, Young Master, but where are you going to get the fund? Unless your parents left you a fortune before disowning you, I cannot see how you'll be able to afford it."

"I may not have the money now but I will definitely have it soon."

Doctor Wang raised his eyebrows after hearing Yuan's confident voice, and he said in a defeated voice, "I understand... but I won't ask you for it."

Sometime later, Doctor Wang began his check-up on Yuan.

"Young Master, your muscles have gotten more robust and refined since I last saw you... again..." Doctor Wang said to him in a voice of disbelief afterward, as he has never seen anything like this before despite decades of experience in the field.

What exactly is Yuan's body made of that allows him to grow such a refined body just from eating nothing but soup every day when even normal, functioning people would require a healthy diet and continuous exercise to maintain it, much less obtain it?

Just like his unknown illness, his physique is a phenomenon of its own.

After putting away his tools, Doctor Wang asked, "Young Master, how has your appetite been lately? Are three bowls of soup enough or do you think we should increase it?"

Doctor Wang also wanted to see if increasing his food intake would help strengthen his body even more.

"Hmm... I think I can handle four— even five bowls of soup now. Meixiu, what do you think? Is that too much for you?" Yuan asked her since she's the one who will be cooking it.

"It's okay. I can handle it." Meixiu said.

"Then let's try 4 bowls of soup for one week to see if you can handle 5." Doctor Wang said.

"I understand," Yuan said.

"Anyways, as always, your body is perfectly healthy, Young Master. But if anything ever happens or you feel even the slightest discomfort, call my

phone immediately."

"I will. Thank you again, Doctor Wang."

Doctor Wang left the apartment shortly after.

"Yuan, before we play, let me look at the information Sister Rou sent me so I know how to sell the treasure," Meixiu said to him after locking the door.

"Okay. I will wait for you inside the game. You're in the backyard of my living quarters, right?"

"Yes."

"Alright. I'll see you inside the game!" Yuan said to her before going inside the game.

After helping Yuan log into the game, Meixiu went into her room and pulled out a thin laptop that she uses mostly for work.

Once she found Yu Rou's message in the form of an email, Meixiu began reading about the website and how the place functions.

[The website is called COPlayerAuctions.]

[The account's information is...]

[In order to sell an item you must...]

[Once you submit your item...]

[After they confirm the item in-game...]

[Make sure you use a VPN when you're on the website just in case people want to track you down...]

[The bank information is...]

Meixiu read through the message multiple times just in case she missed anything before going to the website COPlayerAuctions.

On the front page, after logging into a VPN and the account Yu Rou provided for her, Meixiu clicked on the large 'sell' that was right next to 'buy' and 'trade' and proceeded to type the information that Yuan had given her right before entering the game.

[Type: Auction]

[Item name: Frozen Jade Zither]

[Grade: Divine]

[Quality: Low]

[Type of treasure: Instrument]

[Continent: Eastern Continent]

[Time limit: 7 days]

[Minimal Price: —]

Meixiu stopped at the minimal price since she was never given a number, and she pondered how much a Divine-grade treasure would be worth before giving up and searching the site for comparison.

Of course, nobody was selling anything even close to Divine-grade with the vast majority of them selling common items and Spirit-grade treasures.

"These people are selling Spirit-grade treasures for thousands of dollars?" Meixiu's eyes widened with surprise when she saw the players asking for thousands of dollars for a single Spirit-grade treasure.

However, even more shocking was the auction place where there were treasures being sold for tens of thousands of dollars.

After looking around the website for a couple of minutes, the highest grade of treasure she could find was an Earth-grade treasure that was being auctioned for a whopping 500,000 dollars— half a million dollars!

"Earth-grade... According to Yuan, that's two grades below the Divine-grade, yet it's already being sold at such an astronomical price."

After pondering for some time, Meixiu finally decided on a price and typed it into the website.

[Minimal Price: 100,000,000]

One normally wouldn't dare to put such an astronomical number price tag fearing that nobody would bid, but Meixiu was used to seeing big numbers from working with the Yu Family, hence why she clicked 'sent for review' without hesitation.

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Chapter 287 - Fake Request

A few seconds after Meixiu sent her auction request through the website, a staff member saw her request due to the request being tagged 'urgent' because of the information Meixiu had put in.

"Hmm... What do we have here... What?! Divine-grade treasure?!" The staff's initial thoughts after seeing Meixiu's auction request was that it must have been done by a troll since nobody has sold a treasure higher than Earth-grade since the game went online.

However, no matter how ridiculous the request seemed, it was his job to look through it.

"A Divine-grade zither... An instrument... Eastern Continent... Minimal price... 100 million?!" The staff's eyes bulged at the ridiculous price. However, if this was truly a Divine-grade treasure, that amount of money would be more justified.

"This request is obviously a troll, yet I am somehow hesitant to decline it for some reason..." The staff was feeling perplexed about this situation.

"This account is not only an anonymous account but also a new one, and it's selling a Divine-grade treasure that no player would have at this stage of the game... No, there's actually one person who could possibly have a Divine-grade treasure— Player Yuan. However, would he really sell his Divine-grade treasure so soon after getting it? Even if it's just an instrument, one wouldn't sell such a treasure unless they have something even more valuable..."

"People say he's rich since he isn't swayed by the countless offers to reveal his identity, so he doesn't need the money... Yet here he is, selling a Divine-

grade treasure. Yeah, right."

Despite his suspicion that the request was fake, the staff didn't decline it immediately and sent a note to the anonymous requester.

[If you really have a Divine-grade treasure for sale, you wouldn't mind depositing 10,000 dollars first as a precaution if it turns out to be fake and a waste of our time, right? Once we determine that you really have a Divine-grade treasure, we will not only return the 10,000 but even double it. If you don't respond within 24 hours, we will deem this request to be fake and delete it as well as ban your account.]

Meanwhile, halfway across the world, Meixiu received a notification just as she prepared to close her laptop.

After reading the staff's note, Meixiu responded with a single word.

[Okay.]

Ding!

The staff responded half a minute later with the instructions.

Meixiu followed the staff's instructions and deposited 10,000 dollars on the site without hesitation.

[I have confirmed your deposit. Please tell us the city closest to your location so we can estimate how long it'll take for the nearest staff member to arrive for a meeting.]

The staff behind the computer typed this sentence with trembling hands since he didn't expect this supposed troll account to immediately deposit 10,000 dollars without hesitation.

'Either this troll has a lot of money and is willing to spend 10,000 dollars to waste our time or he's the real deal!' The staff swallowed nervously as he pressed enter to send the message to Meixiu.

Ding!

[I will let you know the location later.]

Since Meixiu doesn't know anything about the game nor its location, she couldn't give the staff a location until she speaks with Yuan.

However, the staff member responding to Meixiu was shaking behind the desk in nervousness.

"Later?! Why the hell are you making me wait?!" He couldn't help but curse out loud, causing his co-workers to look at him.

"What are you shouting about?" They asked him.

"Come look at this!" The staff pointed at his screen.

The workers gathered around him and read his conversation with Meixiu.

"What the? Divine-grade treasure? Is this for real?"

"Fuck! This must either be a troll or Player Yuan!"

"If this is a troll, he's one rich troll to spend 10,000 dollars just to waste our time."

"Right?! I was thinking the same!" The staff said.

"But what if it's real?"

"Then this auction will become the biggest auction on our website to date even if we include the auctions from the old games."

"Too bad we won't know until he gives us a location and we meet to confirm the treasure."

"Should we notify the headquarters or the higher up about this?"

"Not until we verify the treasure."

While the staff waited nervously for Meixiu to give them the location, Meixiu herself laid on the bed with the helmet on her head.

However, she didn't immediately enter Cultivation Online. Instead, she laid there with a nervous expression on her face.

"I am going to see Yuan... And he's going to be completely healthy inside the game..." Meixiu swallowed nervously at this thought.

After lying there for a couple of minutes, Meixiu pressed the power button on the side of the helmet and entered Cultivation Online.

Meanwhile, inside the game, Yuan said to Feng Yuxiang the moment he entered the game.

"Feng Feng, come out. I'll feed you my blood now."

Feng Yuxiang immediately appeared before him with her eyes glistening with anticipation.

Yuan retrieved the Starry Abyss and quickly slit an opening on his finger.

"Here you—"

Before Yuan could even finish his sentence, Feng Yuxiang threw herself at him and immediately began sucking his finger like she was a vampire starved of blood.

Xiao Hua also appeared just in case Feng Yuxiang wouldn't be able to stop sucking Yuan's blood by herself.

"Aaaahh... How refreshing..." Feng Yuxiang stopped sucking a few minutes later, releasing a satisfied sigh afterward.

"Are you okay, Young Master? Should I stop now?" Feng Yuxiang looked at him with her eyes glowing a beautiful golden color.

"I'm okay. You can drink some more." Yuan nodded.

"Thank you, Young Master!" Feng Yuxiang did not hesitate to place Yuan's finger back into her mouth and continued sucking his blood.

A few more minutes later, to Yuan's surprise, Feng Yuxiang's hair suddenly changed colors, turning scarlet red with a fiery feeling to it!

"Aaaaaah~" Feng Yuxiang released Yuan's finger from her mouth after another moment, completely oblivious to the changes in her appearance.

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Chapter 288 - Meeting Meixiu

"Feng Feng... Your hair..." Yuan pointed at her scarlet hair with his finger that was still wet with Feng Yuxiang's saliva.

"Eh? What about my hair?" Feng Yuxiang looked at her hair.

"What! It turned red!" Feng Yuxiang exclaimed in a surprised voice after realizing this, almost like it was completely unexpected.

"Is that supposed to happen?" Yuan asked her a moment later.

"Yes! This means your blood is really working and suppressing the curse on me!" Feng Yuxiang nodded her head.

"What about your powers, phoenix?" Xiao Hua asked her.

"Unfortunately, it's still completely sealed. However, I have no doubt that if I continue sucking the Young Master's blood, my curse will sooner or later disappear entirely! I have lived over 10,000 years like this! A few more years—even a few decades won't affect me!" Feng Yuxiang spoke with enthusiasm in her tone.

Once Feng Yuxiang stopped sucking Yuan's blood for a minute, the small opening on his finger closed by itself within seconds.

As for Feng Yuxiang, her golden eyes and scarlet hair also returned to normal shortly after.

"Oh, right. Meixiu will be joining us today," Yuan said to them.

"Meixiu? Really?" Feng Yuxiang seemed happy to see Meixiu again.

"Yes, she should be here any minute—"

Yuan suddenly stopped speaking when he noticed a familiar presence appear in his backyard out of the blue.

Even though he doesn't have his Divine Sense activated, after becoming a Spirit Master, he gained the ability to naturally detect others' presence as long as they were close enough and he wasn't too distracted.

"I think that's her," Yuan said in an excited voice before he stood up and walked towards the backyard.

Once he reached the door that led to the backyard, Yuan took a deep breath and opened the door.

Meanwhile, Meixiu, who had just entered the game, turned around when she heard some noises coming from behind her.

"You are..."

Meixiu's eyes widened with shock when she saw the handsome young man standing at the opened door a few meters away from her.

Although his appearance slightly differed from his body in the real world, Meixiu could instantly tell that she was looking at Yuan at glance.

Even though it has been at least a decade since she last saw him in such a perfect and healthy appearance, Meixiu would never forget Yuan's lively face and unique charisma, especially his clear eyes that radiated with innocence.

Meanwhile, in Yuan's eyes, other than her maid uniform and height, Meixiu looked almost no different from how he remembered her. Long silky black hair, a neatly cut and even bang, crystal clear black eyes, and her unique characteristic— a naturally bored-looking face.

Of course, she was much taller than the child from back then, not to mention her beautiful face that would not lose to even the top beauties in

the Dragon Essence Temple such as Xuan Wuhan or Fei Yuyan, perhaps even beating them in certain criteria.

"Yu...Yuan?" Meixiu mumbled his name in a dazed voice.

"It's been a while, Meixiu. You're even taller than Yu Rou now." Yuan slowly approached her with a handsome smile on his face.

"..."

Almost as though she didn't know what to do or how to react, Meixiu remained standing there like a frozen statue until Yuan was practically standing in front of her.

"I have always wanted to do this..."

Yuan suddenly opened his arms wide and embraced Meixiu before speaking in a gentle voice, "Thank you, Meixiu... for taking care of Yu Rou and me for all these years..."

"Yuan..."

Two streams of glistening tears suddenly appeared on Meixiu's beautiful face, quickly staining Yuan's shoulders.

Meixiu slowly lifted her arms a moment later before returning Yuan's hug, yet she didn't say anything, only embracing Yuan in silence.

"They seem very close with each other." Feng Yuxiang mumbled in a mosquito-like voice as she peeked her head from inside the house and watched them hug each other.

"..."

Xiao Hua also did the same without moving her mouth, watching their reunion in silence.

Sometime later, Yuan removed his arms from her and stepped back.

"Meixiu, let me introduce you to my friends first," Yuan said to her before turning around to look at the opened door.

"Xiao Hua, Feng Feng, come here," he said to them.

A few moments later, the two of them left the house and stood beside Yuan.

"You already know her but this is Feng Yuxiang, also known as Feng Feng, and she's a phoenix." Yuan pointed to Feng Feng and said.

He then pointed to Xiao Hua and said, "This is Xiao Hua, my first friend in this world, and she's like another little sister to me."

Xiao Hua nodded her head at Meixiu after the introduction.

"Now let me introduce you to Meixiu." Yuan said, and he continued, "Xiao Hua, Feng Feng, this is Meixiu, who is like a family member to me since we've always been near each other since childhood. And just like Yu Rou, she has helped me tremendously throughout the years. It wouldn't be an exaggeration even if I said that I wouldn't be alive now if it were not for the two of them and their support for me."

"Alongside Yu Rou, she's one of the most important people in my life."

"I've said this before, but any friends of the Young Master are also a friend of mine! If you ever need help, don't hesitate to come to me for help!" Feng Yuxiang said to Meixiu.

"Xiao Hua too."

"It's nice to meet all of you." Meixiu nodded.

And then she focused her gaze on Yuan.

'Especially you, Yuan...' A rare smile appeared on Meixiu's face as she stared at his handsome face.

Sometime later, they returned to the house and took a seat on the couches in the living room.

"Let me brew some tea for us." Feng Yuxiang said to them before going to the kitchen.

Meanwhile, Yuan began telling Meixiu about his experience in cultivation, starting from the beginning when he first met with Xiao Hua to how he got this point.

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Chapter 289 - Long Chen City

"So during the Inner Court Disciple Examination, I fought the Jade Frog for the second time, and I—"

"Young Master, I'm back with the tea." Feng Yuxiang returned to the living room an hour after she left to make tea, but since Yuan was too absorbed in telling Meixiu his experience with the game, he didn't notice how much time had passed.

It was the same for Meixiu, who was simply too absorbed in Yuan's story and his liveliness that made her forget about the passage of time.

"Thank you, Feng Feng," Yuan said to her as she poured the tea for them.

"Hm? What kind of tea is this? It's all red." Yuan asked her after picking up the teacup and noticing the red water that resembled watered-down blood.

"It's tea made from a valuable type of herb that can boost one's mental strength. People call it Crimson Lotus Tea." Feng Yuxiang said.

Yuan proceeded to take a sip of this Crimson Lotus Tea after blowing it a few times.

"Oh? It's sweet." Yuan mumbled in a surprised voice afterward, and he chugged the entire cup a moment later.

Ding!

[You have gained the following effect from consuming Crimson Lotus Tea]

[Mental Strength +1,500]

Meixiu also gained the same stats after drinking the tea.

"Feng Feng, I drank a tea called Phoenix Blossom Tea before and it increased my Soul Strength. Is there a limit to how much benefit one can obtain from drinking tea or consuming treasures in general?" Yuan asked her afterward.

Feng Yuxiang nodded, "Of course there is a limit, Young Master. If one can obtain strength from drinking the same tea every day, there wouldn't be so many cultivators risking their lives in the cultivation world."

"When it comes to treasures that can be consumed, especially teas, there is a limit to how much benefit one can gain before their body stops benefitting from that specific treasure no matter how much more they consume."

"Most treasures will only work once before one can no longer benefit from them. As for treasures that can benefit you multiple times, they are too few and far between." Feng Yuxiang explained to him.

"I see..." Yuan mumbled.

"Anyways, I would still drink this tea even if I don't gain anything from it." Yuan extended his cup and continued, "Can I get another cup?"

"Of course you can." Feng Yuxiang poured him another cup.

Sometime later, Meixiu said, "Yuan, I have created an auction request for the Frozen Jade Zither, but it still needs to be verified. The staff asked me to give them my closest city so they can meet up and look at the treasure."

Yuan nodded and turned to ask Feng Yuxiang, "Where's the nearest city?"

"That would be Long Chen City, which was obviously named after the Dragon Essence Temple's Founder. And it's about 20 miles from this place." Feng Yuxiang said.

"I see... Since there's still some time left before the Mystic Realm, let's try to sell the treasure." Yuan said to Meixiu.

"Wait a second, Young Master. What are you trying to sell? The Frozen Jade Zither?" Feng Yuxiang asked him.

Yuan nodded, "That's right. I don't really have a need for it since I already have the Soul Ensnaring Zither."

"Why? Do you need money for something?"

"Yes."

"If you want, I can give you some..." Feng Yuxiang said, even reaching for her spatial ring.

"It's fine, Feng Feng. I can just sell the zither. And you should already know by now that I don't like having everything handed to me without giving any effort myself."

"I understand..." Feng Yuxiang nodded in a somewhat dejected manner.

"I need to let the Seniors know that I'll be leaving the sect before I actually leave."

A few moments later, Yuan called Elder Xuan with his communication jade slip.

"Hello? Disciple Yuan?"

"Senior Xuan, I would like to leave the sect for a bit."

"Leaving the sect? Where are you going? The Mystic Realm is just three days away!"

"I have some business at Long Chen City with my friend. It shouldn't take long— probably a couple of hours."

"Oh, if it's just Long Chen City, go ahead. I would accompany you, but I am extremely busy right now and the other elders as well so you'll have to go alone. The Dragon Essence Temple is also closely associated with Long Chen City so there shouldn't be any problems if you go there, especially if

you're wearing the sect's uniform. However, if anything happens, don't be afraid to use the life-saving treasures we gave you." Elder Xuan said to him.

"I understand. Thank you, Senior Xuan."

"Stay safe."

After hanging up, Yuan said to Meixiu, "You can tell them to meet us in Long Chen City."

Meixiu nodded her head before logging off and going to her laptop.

[Long Chen City.]

Ding!

A response quickly returned ten seconds later.

[We can be at the northern gates within half an hour. Are you able to make it there within that time?]

[Yes.]

[Then we will see you there in half an hour.]

"I'm going online to meet the client!" The staff said after closing the chat.

"Do you want us to come with you just in case?"

"No, I can do this by myself. I'm not going to let you guys take my credits."

"Hahaha! I bet you it's going to be a troll, anyways!"

"You can keep the credits! If you meet Player Yuan, don't forget to ask for his autograph! Hahaha!"

Despite his co-workers laughing at him, the man who accepted Meixiu's auction request went to the gaming room that was located at the same building he worked at.

"Luckily for me, I didn't leave Long Chen City after failing to learn more about Player Yuan at the Dragon Essence Temple." The man sighed to himself before lying on one of the ten available beds there and wearing the helmet on his head.

"Let's hope this won't be a waste of time..." he sighed before pressing the power button and entering the game.

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Chapter 290 - Verifying The Treasure

After returning to the game, Meixiu told Yuan about the situation.

"The northern entrance at Long Chen City in 30 minutes, huh. We can arrive in a few minutes if we fly there." Yuan nodded.

"However, since we're going to be meeting with a player, we should hide our identities."

Yuan turned to look at Xiao Hua and asked her, "Xiao Hua, do you have another mask like the Black Jade Mask to give to Meixiu?"

Xiao Hua shook her head.

"If you need a mask, I have one, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Really? Do you think we can borrow it for now?"

Feng Yuxiang nodded and pulled out a red mask from her spatial ring a moment later.

Unlike the Black Jade Mask that was large enough to cover one's face, this mask only covered the upper half of one's face, leaving the chin and mouth exposed. Furthermore, it was red in color with some gold outlines.

"You can keep it. I tried selling it years ago but eventually gave up and tossed it with the other things I couldn't sell." Feng Yuxiang handed it to Meixiu in a casual manner.

[Crimson Mask]

[Grade: Spirit]

[Quality: High]

[Mental Strength Required: 1,000]

[Description: A beautiful red mask that increases your Mental Defense by 2,000]

"Thank you, Feng Feng." Meixiu accepted the mask.

"Even though it's a treasure and you don't have any cultivation, you should be able to wear it after consuming the Crimson Lotus Tea." Feng Yuxiang said.

And she continued, "Speaking of your cultivation, do you intend on staying as a mortal forever, or are you going to start cultivating soon?"

"I..." Meixiu turned to look at Yuan for help since she didn't know anything about cultivators.

"I think you should become a cultivator, Meixiu. This way, you can protect yourself in this world that's full of unreasonable people." Yuan said to her.

"I will protect you whenever we're together, but there may be times when we're separated."

Meixiu nodded, "Okay, I will become a cultivator."

A few moments later, Yuan retrieved the flying sword and said to Meixiu, "I can carry you."

"Eh?" Meixiu's eyes widened after hearing Yuan's words. He wants to carry her?

"Ahem!" Feng Yuxiang suddenly cleared her throat before speaking, "If you want, I can carry you instead..."

Meixiu nodded and said to Yuan in a somewhat bashful voice "I'm sorry, but I don't think I'm ready to be carried by you... yet..."

Yuan didn't understand what she meant by that but nodded his head regardless.

"Okay, I'll leave Meixiu to you, Feng Feng."

Sometime later, Yuan jumped on the flying sword and flew towards the sky with Xiao Hua.

Feng Yuxiang followed them after carrying Meixiu like before.

"Xiao Hua, you mentioned that some people are able to fly before Spirit Grandmaster. Do you think I can learn to fly now that I am a Spirit Master?" Yuan asked her while they flew toward Long Chen City slowly.

"In order to fly, Brother Yuan must learn Qi Manifestation to a certain extent, where you release the spiritual energy inside your Dantian outside and control the gravity around you."

"How does one learn Qi Manifestation? Is there a technique for it?" Yuan asked.

"No, Qi Manifestation is something one must learn by themselves."

"I see... I will try it later." Yuan nodded.

Yuan and the others descended from the sky a few minutes later once they could see Long Chen City in the distance.

Once they returned to the ground, they walked a few hundred meters until they could see the entrance to the city.

"This is the northern entrance, right?" Yuan asked Feng Yuxiang.

"That's correct."

Thus, they began waiting for the staff member from the auction site.

"Xiao Hua, Feng Feng, can you hide for now? There's a chance the players can use you to identify us." Meixiu suddenly said to them.

"Oh, Meixiu's right. We're trying to hide our identity." Yuan agreed with Meixiu.

Xiao Hua and Feng Yuxiang nodded their heads and disappeared by returning to Yuan's body.

"Wow..." Meixiu mumbled in a dazed voice after seeing this scene.

About ten minutes later, they could see a skinny man in his late twenties wearing plain clothes approaching them with a nervous smile on his face.

"Hello... I am a staff member at COPlayerAuctions... Are you the ones selling the Frozen Jade Zither?" The staff said in a nervous voice, mostly because of the invisible but powerful aura coming from Yuan, who stood there menacingly in the staff's eyes.

'A black mask... Could it really be? Player Yuan?' The staff swallowed nervously at this thought.

"We are," Meixiu said.

"Hello, esteemed guests. You can call me Lee, and I am here to verify the Frozen Jade Zither's legitimacy before we begin the auction."

"How are you going to verify the treasure?" Meixiu then asked.

"I just need to verify the grade of the treasure. However, before we do that, let's go somewhere more private. There are too many people around here."

Yuan and Meixiu then followed this person named Lee into the woodland behind them.

A few minutes later, they stopped.

"Now, if you could, please take out the Frozen Jade Zither. I just need to verify the grade and quality to make sure it's real. Also, you can rest

assured that I won't touch the treasure until we officially begin the auction with your approval," said Lee.

Meixiu turned to look at Yuan since he was the one who had the treasure.

After nodding his head, Yuan retrieved the Frozen Jade Zither from his spatial ring and held it in front of Lee.

"This is..." Lee felt the chills throughout his body the moment the Frozen Jade Zither appeared, and the atmosphere in that area also became colder.

Lee narrowed his eyes at the zither.

[Frozen Jade Zither]

[Grade: Divine]

[Quality: Low]

[Mental Strength Requirement: 35,000]

[Soul Strength Requirement: 50,000]

[Description: Can create music notes that will freeze one's heart and soul]

"R-Real... It's really a Divine-grade treasure!" Lee subconsciously took a few steps with a shocked expression on his face after seeing the zither's stats.

Chapter 291 - The Treasure Is Real!

'I-It's real! Since this Divine-grade treasure is real, there's a very good chance this person in the black mask is...' Lee turned to look at Yuan with a shocked face, looking like he'd just received a revelation.

"Have you verified it?" Meixiu suddenly asked him.

"Y-Yes! I have! Thank you very much!" Lee quickly responded in a startled manner.

"What should we do from this point?" Meixiu then asked.

Lee swallowed heavily and took a deep breath to calm himself down before speaking, "Before we continue, I have a few questions for you. The questions, of course, are optional, so you don't have to answer them if you don't want to. However, it would be in your and the bidders' best interest that they have more information on the treasure."

Meixiu nodded her head.

"Ahem! First and foremost, where did you obtain this treasure? A brief background is fine as well." Lee then asked.

"It was obtained from an event," Yuan responded.

'What a young voice! Could Player Yuan be a youngster?!' Lee cried inwardly after hearing Yuan's voice.

Lee swallowed nervously and continued to ask, "I-If you don't mind me asking, was it obtained from the Zither Competition that occurred

recently?"

Lee really wanted to straight out ask Yuan if he was really Player Yuan but due to their anonymous account, such a question would break the terms of service, as anonymous accounts are called anonymous for a reason. With that being said, as long as he doesn't ask questions that directly ask for their identity, it would be fine.

"It's..."

Yuan opened his mouth to speak, but Meixiu quickly interrupted, "You may move onto the next question."

Lee nodded and immediately asked the next question without any complaints, "Then let's continue to the auction itself."

"You requested for the minimum bid to start at 100 million dollars, is that correct?"

"Yes," Meixiu said.

"The time limit for the auction will be 7 days, is that correct?"

"Yes."

"Do you have any special requests for the auction?"

"No."

"Do you accept trades, or do you want money only?"

"Money only."

Meixiu answered Lee's questions as straightforwardly as possible.

"Thank you. Now, allow me to explain to you how the auction will proceed since this appears to be your first time working with us." Lee said.

And he continued, "Once we get your approval and receive the treasure, we will immediately begin the auction. There is normally a line based on a first come first serve rule, but we will make an exception this time and give your treasure priority due to its value."

"At the end of the auction, the highest bidder will pay the money to the website, which will be transferred to your account after deducting the service fees, which is 10 percent of the total amount. Once we transfer the money to your account, we will hand over the treasure to the buyer. Do you have any questions so far?"

Meixiu pondered for a moment before speaking, "Are there any assurances for us? What if you take the treasure and run with it?"

"I understand your worries, esteemed guest, and while I personally don't have anything to reassure you, I do hope the website's reputation that has been built upon decades of trust will reassure you to some extent."

"Our website, COPlayerAuctions, has over ten million successful transactions since its foundation with millions of dollars transferred every day. In total, our website has earned tens of billions of dollars for the players. Furthermore, all of this was done without a single fraud transaction. While we have been accused of stealing before by people for clout and money, plenty of times at that, we've been proven innocent for every single case."

Lee explained their website's history and its trustworthiness.

"If that's not enough to convince you to trust us, we will even deposit the requested minimal amount— 100,000,000 dollars into your account temporarily. Of course, you won't be able to withdraw it until after the bid."

"What do you think?"

After pondering for a moment, Meixiu nodded, "Okay."

"Great! Can you give me about 30— no, 15 minutes to prepare things? I will log off and approve of the auction as well as notify the higher

management so they can transfer the money to your account. Once that's done, I will return for the treasure."

"Okay."

"Thank you!"

Lee logged off a few seconds later.

Yuan and Meixiu also logged off shortly after.

Meanwhile, after logging off, Lee removed the console from his head before rushing out of the room with an ecstatic look on his face.

"It's real! It's real! It's really real! Hahaha!" Lee laughed out loud as he ran in the hallways, quickly returning to his workroom.

Bang!

Lee opened the door with force and shouted loudly, "It's real! The treasure is real! I verified it! It's really a Divine-grade treasure! And the person selling it was most likely Player Yuan!"

Everybody in the room stopped whatever they were doing and turned to look at him with dumbfounded expressions on their faces.

"W-Wait a second... Are you serious? The auction request is real?" One of Lee's co-workers asked him in a trembling voice.

"Yes! I will explain it later since I need to call upper management asap!"

Lee immediately went to pick up his phone and dialed a number.

"Hello, this is Lee. My staff code is 19X6SE... This call is regarding one of the auction requests I had received recently..."

Lee proceeded to explain to the upper management about the Frozen Jade Zither, which immediately caused a stir within the upper management.

"Are you sure?! That Player Yuan might be selling his Divine-grade treasure?!"

"Yes, I am fairly certain that was Player Yuan. His appearance and black mask matched the descriptions from those who saw him at the Zither Competition!" Lee said with confidence in his voice.

"This is huge news! And this auction... we're going to make sure the entire world knows of it! Don't mess this up, Lee! Your head is on the line here!"

"Yessir!" Lee said before hanging up and going to his computer to speak with Meixiu through the website.

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Chapter 292 - Announcing The Auction To The World

[Hello, this is Lee. I have just spoken with the upper management, and they have agreed to proceed with the auction. 100 million dollars should be deposited into your account within the next few minutes.]

After sitting in front of her laptop for a couple of minutes after she logged off from Cultivation Online, Meixiu received this message from Lee on COPlayerAuctions.

And just like Lee had promised, 100 million dollars was added to her account's wallet.

[I have received the money.] Meixiu typed.

[Great, then we may proceed with the auction. Once again, the bid will last for 7 days, and you will receive the money within 48 hours after the auction with the service fees already deducted, which is 10 percent of the total amount.]

[I understand.]

[Then I will meet you inside the game in five minutes to retrieve the treasure from you.]

[Okay.]

After her message, Meixiu went to explain to Yuan the situation.

"They have deposited 100 million dollars into our account, but we cannot withdraw it until after the auction."

"That's fine."

They returned to Cultivation Online a few minutes later and waited for Lee to log in.

Once Lee also returned to the game, Yuan handed the Frozen Jade Zither to Lee, who immediately tossed it inside his spatial ring.

Even though spatial rings are expensive, every staff member working for the website was given one so that they can safely secure the treasures given to them.

"Thank you for trusting us. We will not disappoint you. The auction will begin tomorrow after we advertise the auction to the world," said Lee to them before logging off the game.

"What should we do now?" Meixiu asked Yuan afterward.

"Want to hang out at Long Chen City for the rest of the day? We can eat food and look at stores together. Perhaps we can even look for a cultivation technique for you." Yuan said.

"Eat food and look at stores?" Meixiu mumbled.

'Isn't this basically a date?' she wondered inwardly.

After a moment of silence, she spoke, "But I already have a cultivation technique. It was given to me when I first started."

"Oh, the basic cultivation technique? I have it as well but I never used it since I have a better one. And if you have a better cultivation technique, you will be able to cultivate faster." Yuan said.

"I understand." Meixiu nodded.

Feng Yuxiang's voice suddenly resounded, "I would give you a cultivation technique but I don't have any, and as a Divine Beast, we don't really need any cultivation techniques since we absorb the spiritual energy in the air

naturally. Of course, having one would help, but it won't help me since I cannot increase my cultivation base because of the curse."

"Xiao Hua, what about our cultivation technique? Do you think Meixiu can learn it as well?" Yuan then asked her.

"If Sister Meixiu agrees to help Xiao Hua with her legacy," she replied.

"What do you think, Meixiu?" Yuan then asked her.

"Okay." Meixiu nodded.

"Great! Thank you, Xiao Hua!"

Sometime later, Yuan and Meixiu made their way towards Long Chen City, and since Yuan was wearing his Inner Court uniform, the guards allowed them to enter the city without paying any fees, even greeting them with respect.

Meanwhile, in the outside world, the world was taken by surprise when COPlayerAuctions, the leading market for Cultivation Online, announced their latest high-profile auction.

"What?! There's going to be a Divine-grade treasure being auctioned off later?! Impossible!"

"It's real! The website made an official announcement just a few minutes ago! They have also verified the treasure!"

"Heavens! Who could possibly sell a Divine-grade treasure at this stage of the game, much less have one?!"

"I can only think of Player Yuan when it comes to having Divine-grade treasures!"

"Could this treasure be one of Player Yuan's treasures?!"

"That's very likely, but the website didn't mention Player Yuan's name, which is odd considering that it would definitely bring more attention to the

auction if they attached his name to the auction!"

"Who knows, really. We can only wait for more information about this auction."

While the news spread from the peoples' mouth, it was also mentioned on the news and the internet, especially Player Yuan's dedicated forums which blew up with speculations regarding this auction being related to Player Yuan.

[Player Yuan might have auctioned off his Divine-grade treasure!]

[There's a high possibility that this treasure belongs to Player Yuan!]

[The auction will start at a whopping 100 million dollars, becoming one of the most expensive auctions right off the bat!]

While the internet raged with excitement, the Legacy and wealthy families out there began preparing their money for the treasure.

"What a damn pity this Divine-grade treasure is only an instrument! If it was a sword or any other weapon, I wouldn't be so hesitant about joining the auction!"

"Then should we ignore this auction?"

"No, let's still try to buy it. Who knows when such an opportunity might arrive again. However, we won't go all out."

Many people had the same sentiment towards this auction since the Divine-grade treasure was only an instrument and not an actual weapon.

However, not every family had the same opinion. In fact, it was the complete opposite for wealthy families with a musical background. In their eyes, the zither, one of the most popular instruments ever since Player Yuan's debut at the Zither Competition, was akin to the holy grail, something they must get their hands on!

Thus, it was a chaotic scene across the world for most musical families and companies.

Meanwhile, at the Yu Family, Tang Lee slammed the table with an excited expression on her face after hearing about the auction, and she said, "We must get our hands on this Divine-grade zither!"

Yu Yong nodded his head in agreement and said, "Not only will this benefit our players since most of them use the zither but we might even get to know this Player Yuan's identity if we manage to buy it."

"I will call our accountants right now. We can't let the other families get their hands on this treasure!" Tang Lee immediately pulled out her cell phone and began calling people.

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Chapter 293 - We Should Do This More Often

After speaking with a dozen accountants, Tang Lee closed her phone and said to Yu Yong, "We're ready to bid whenever the auction begins."

"Good. This is going to be a fierce fight. The other families won't let us obtain the zither easily since whichever family gets it will have a massive advantage over the other families." Yu Yong nodded.

Meanwhile, similar situations played out in the other musical families.

"We must get our hands on this Frozen Jade Zither! We cannot let the Yu Family get it or our current advantage will instantly disappear!"

"The Yu Family may be rich, but their resources are not unlimited, especially not after what happened to their golden goose!"

Wealthy families around the world prepared their bank for the upcoming auction whilst the common folks waited for the spectacle.

Meanwhile, inside Cultivation Online and the Dragon Essence Temple, Elder Shan knocked on Fei Yuyan's doors.

"Master? Do you need something?" Fei Yuyan greeted her at the door, but she found it unusual that Elder Shan would visit her unannounced.

"Here, Disciple Yuan asked me to give this to you." Elder Shan extended her hand with a scroll in her grasp.

"What's this?" Fei Yuyan raised her eyebrows as she accepted the scroll.

"It's the Divine-rank technique the two of you had obtained at the zither competition. Apparently, he's done with it." Elder Shan explained.

"Wait... He's done with it already? How long has it been since the competition? A week?" Feng Yuxiang mumbled in a dazed voice.

"He handed it to me a couple of days ago so it actually took him much shorter than that."

"Unbelievable... I cannot imagine learning a Divine-rank technique in such a short time. His comprehension abilities are simply god-like." Fei Yuyan sighed in a defeated voice, realizing that she will never be at Yuan's level.

"By the way, the last spot for the Mystic Realm... It's Disciple Yuan, isn't it?" Fei Yuyan suddenly asked.

"Is it that obvious?" Elder Shan smiled.

"Of course," she nodded.

"Don't tell anybody about this, though. The Core Disciples won't be happy if they learn that an Inner Court disciple had taken their spot— a new disciple who recently joined, at that." Elder Shan said.

"Don't worry, Master. I won't tell anybody." Fei Yuyan promised.

"Anyways, good luck with the technique. I've got a few more things to do before the Mystic Realm."

"Thank you, Master."

"Don't thank me— thank Disciple Yuan the next time you see him. Maybe even a kiss." Elder Shan chuckled.

"M-Master! Don't make such jokes! It's not funny! We... The two of us live in different worlds. I don't qualify to be with someone like him." Fei Yuyan sighed in a dejected manner.

"..."

Elder Shan didn't expect Fei Yuyan to respond so seriously, leaving her speechless.

After a moment of awkward silence, Elder Shan said, "If you really like him, I don't think it's impossible. You never know—he might even make you his Dao Companion."

"Dao Companion...?" Fei Yuyan stared at Elder Shan with wide eyes filled with surprise.

"Don't underestimate yourself, Disciple Fei. You're one of the Three Graceful Fairies, have some more confidence in yourself. And if you don't ask him, how else are you going to find out?"

"I see... Thank you, Master, for your advice." Fei Yuyan nodded.

Sometime later, Elder Shan left Fei Yuyan's living quarters.

"Disciple romance, huh? If only there was someone like Disciple Yuan during my disciple days..." Elder Shan returned home with a solemn look on her face.

Meanwhile, in Long Chen City, Yuan and Meixiu walked side by side as they strolled through the city.

"Senior Disciple, how about some chicken skewers? It's on me!"

A middle-aged man working by the streets suddenly called out to Disciple Yuan, offering them free food.

Yuan immediately nodded, "Thank you."

"This is the least I can do for the Dragon Essence Temple that has helped our community a lot!" The worker laughed as he handed Yuan two sticks of chicken skewers.

"Here you go." Yuan handed the other chicken skewer to Meixiu.

"Thank you..." Meixiu accepted the chicken skewer.

After eating the skewer, Yuan sighed, "That chicken skewer made me even more hungry. Do you want to sit down and eat some food?"

"Whatever you want to do," Meixiu responded.

Yuan nodded and took her to a random restaurant where they spent the next hour sitting down and eating food.

Inside the restaurant, Yuan displayed his amazing eating abilities to Meixiu who was only slightly surprised by his eating habits.

"The food in this game... the taste is too realistic..." Meixiu was more shocked by how well her tastebuds worked inside the game, almost like she was eating real food.

"Right? This is actually my favorite part about Cultivation Online! I am only limited to soup outside, but in this world, I can eat whatever I want!" Yuan said with a bright smile on his face.

After they finished eating and Yuan paid the tab which was given a discount because of his status as an Inner Court disciple at the Dragon Essence Temple, Yuan and Meixiu continued to wander the city until they eventually found something that would pique their interest and cause them to stop momentarily, almost like two lovers on a date.

As the sky grew darker, Yuan and Meixiu left the city and flew back to the Dragon Essence Temple with the help of Xiao Hua and Feng Yuxiang.

"I had fun today, Meixiu. We should definitely do this more often— just spending our days leisurely." Yuan said to her after they returned to his backyard.

Meixiu nodded with a slightly rosy face that was hidden by the darkness outside, "I had fun too."

"Anyways, before we log off for the night, let's see if Meixiu can learn Heaven's Secret Art." Yuan said to Xiao Hua once they went back into the house.

"Okay." Xiao Hua nodded her small head before taking out her book.

After giving Meixiu some instructions, Yuan sat down in the lotus position with Meixiu sitting right beside him.

However, before she started, Xiao Hua said, "By the way, Sister Meixiu, are you sure you're willing to help Xiao Hua with her legacy? Xiao Hua can only teach you the technique if you agree."

Although she didn't know anything about Xiao Hua's legacy, Meixiu nodded her head.

A few moments later, Xiao Hua began reading her book, quickly filling the room with incomprehensible words, almost like she was mumbling gibberish.

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Chapter 294 - Frozen Jade Zither Auction

An hour after Xiao Hua started reading her book, she suddenly closed it and stopped reciting the technique.

"What do you think, Meixiu?" Yuan asked her afterward.

Meixiu shook her head and said, "I didn't understand a thing."

"That's completely expected since it normally takes months, even years to learn a cultivation technique at this level— that is unless you're Brother Yuan, of course." Xiao Hua said.

And she continued, "Although Xiao Hua appreciates Sister Meixiu for agreeing to help Xiao Hua with her legacy, Xiao Hua thinks you should find a more suitable cultivation technique."

"Eh? Shouldn't you give Meixiu some more time to learn the technique? I think it's still too early for her to give up." Yuan said.

However, Xiao Hua shook her head and said, "Xiao Hua can tell. Unlike Brother Yuan, Sister Meixiu was unable to remain focused the entire time. Even if she cannot learn the technique in a few hours like Brother Yuan, she should at least have the ability to remain focused."

"When one cannot remain focused during a certain cultivation technique, it usually means they are not suited for the cultivation technique, so they won't learn it no matter how long they study it." Feng Yuxiang suddenly jumped in.

"I also tried to learn the technique but was unable to focus even slightly so I gave up after a few minutes." Feng Yuxiang shrugged.

"That's because you're a Divine Beast. Only human cultivators are able to learn Xiao Hua's technique," she said.

"What kind of cultivation is it, anyway? I'm kind of interested." Feng Yuxiang said.

However, Xiao Hua shook her head and said, "It's a secret."

"Sorry, Meixiu, but I guess you can only cultivate the basic cultivation technique for now until we find you a more suitable cultivation technique," Yuan said to Meixiu.

"I don't mind," she said in a calm voice.

Sometime later, Yuan and Meixiu logged off the game.

After logging off, Meixiu went to cook dinner while Yuan cultivated in his room.

Once dinner was served, Meixiu went to sleep. As for Yuan, he spent the entire night cultivating like usual.

The following morning, after breakfast, Meixiu took her laptop to Yuan's room and said, "The auction will start in a few minutes."

"How much do you think we'll be able to sell the Frozen Jade Zither for?" Yuan asked her.

"Who knows, but it should be more than enough to support us for a very long time," Meixiu said as she pulled up the website.

The first thing that popped up when she entered the website was the words 'Divine-grade Treasure Auction'. Upon clicking this pop-up, she was immediately taken to the auction.

[Frozen Jade Zither]

[Grade: Divine]

[Quality: Low]

[Type of treasure: Instrument]

[Requirements: 35,000 Mental Strength, 50,000 Soul Strength]

[Description: Obtained from an event]

[Time limit: 7 days]

[Starting Price: 100,000,000]

[Minimal Bid: 100,000]

[Time until auction starts: 14:39]

[Current Bidders: 150,241,777]

"Wow, there are over 150 million people on this page as of this moment," Meixiu mumbled as she watched the number increase by thousands with every passing second.

However, despite the massive amount of 'bidders' there, the majority of them were only there to spectate the real bidders fight each other for the first Divine-grade treasure ever being sold.

Meanwhile, across the world, news outlets and online streamers were all focused on the auction.

As the timer approached zero, the anticipation from people around the world only heightened.

By the time there was only one minute left, the auction had amassed a grand total of 300 million 'bidders', breaking the website's record by ten folds, and this number would only increase.

[0:04]

[0:03]

[0:02]

[0:01]

[0:00]

[Auction begins!]

The second the auction started, the 100,000,000 starting price suddenly jumped up by a massive 10 million dollars!

[Ling Family has bid 110,000,000!]

[110,000,000]

However, not even ten seconds later, the number jumped again!

[Anonymous has bid 125,000,000!]

[125,000,000]

The number continued to grow with every passing minute, and in just ten short minutes, the price for the Frozen Jade Zither had reached 200,000,000 dollars!

[Yu Family has bid 200,000,000!]

Furthermore, in order to bid in an auction, one must actually have the funds available and ready in their account!

The explosive increase shocked the majority of the spectators, but in the eyes of these wealthy families, the fight was just beginning!

The website reached a peak of 500 million 'bidders' an hour after the auction started, slowly decreasing once the bidding also slowed down.

[Lotus Family has bid 258,000,000!]

[Chen Family has bid 258,500,000!]

[DreamSlayer has bid 260,000,000!]

[Anonymous has bid 261,000,000!]

"It's already at 260 million, Yuan," Meixiu said to him in a calm voice.

While the number may seem astronomical to the average person, in Meixiu's eyes, who has seen larger numbers, she didn't show too much reaction to it.

As for Yuan, who used to earn similar numbers in a month from playing professionally also didn't show much excitement when he heard the amount. In his mind, he only needed enough money to support himself and Meixiu.

"I see... Anyways, there are still seven days. Let's leave it for now." Yuan said.

"Okay."

After closing her laptop, Meixiu helped Yuan enter the game before she went to her own room and entered the game herself.

Inside the game, Yuan said to Meixiu, "I will be participating in the Mystic Realm in a few days, but we will be leaving the sect sometime today. Do you want to come with me, Meixiu?"

Meixiu nodded, "Yes."

After all, if she's not with Yuan, she has nowhere else to go, nor was there anything for her to do.

Sometime later, Yuan could feel the communication jade slip in his pocket tremble.

"Disciple Yuan, please come to the sect master's headquarters. We're going to be leaving the sect in an hour." Elder Xuan's voice resounded from the

jade slip.

"Okay," Yuan replied before leaving his living quarters with Meixiu shortly after.

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Chapter 295 - Dao Companion

"Yuan, should I wear my mask as well?" Meixiu asked him before leaving the house.

"Oh, right. I almost forgot. Let's wear our mask just in case." Yuan nodded as he wore the Black Jade Mask.

Meixiu followed and wore her Crimson Mask before following Yuan outside.

"Hmm? Disciple Yuan? Where are you going? And who's that beside you? She doesn't look like a disciple." Min Li noticed them and called out to him from her windows.

"Good morning, Disciple Min. I am heading to the sect master's headquarters right now," said Yuan.

"Sect master's headquarters? Did you do something again? Most disciples go there only when they're in trouble with the Sect Master," Min Li said in a slightly worried voice.

"Haha... No, I am not in trouble. I'm meeting with Elder Xuan there since we're about to leave the sect for the Mystic Realm."

"W-Wait a second... The Mystic Realm? Don't tell me you're going to participate in it?" Min Li stared at him with wide eyes, but after she recalled his talents, her shock almost instantly disappeared.

"That's right." Yuan nodded.

"I-I see... Well... Good luck, I guess..." Min Li was speechless.

"Oh, and this is my friend, Meixiu. See you later, Disciple Min!"

Yuan left the place shortly after, leaving Min Li standing by the window with a dazed look on her face.

"That was Min Li, my neighbor, and a fellow disciple. She's from a really powerful and influential family from what I heard," Yuan introduced her to Meixiu after they left.

Sometime later, they arrived at the sect master's headquarters.

Knock *Knock*

Yuan knocked on the door loudly after arriving at the doorstep

"It's me, Disciple Yuan!"

The door opened a few moments later and Elder Xuan appeared before them.

"Welcome, Disciple Yuan—" Elder Xuan stopped speaking when he noticed Meixiu standing beside him.

"Who's this?" he then asked.

"This is my friend, Meixiu. I hope you don't mind her tagging along with us." Yuan said to him.

"Your friend...?" Elder Xuan raised his eyebrows.

He then said, "Let's assemble with the others for now. We'll see what the Sect Master has to say about this."

Yuan and Meixiu followed Elder Xuan inside the building to meet with Long Yijun, the high-ranking sect elders, as well as the participants.

"We've been waiting for you, Disciple Yuan— Hm? Who's that?" Long Yijun asked the moment he noticed the person with a feminine figure standing next to Yuan.

"This is my friend, Meixiu, and I'd like to bring her with me," Yuan said.

"Your friend...?" Everyone in the room turned to look at Meixiu with raised eyebrows.

"You say she's your friend, but she's actually your Dao Companion or something, right?" Elder Shan chuckled after a moment of silence.

"Dao Companion? What's that?" Yuan asked in a puzzled voice, forgetting that he'd heard this term before.

"You don't know? A Dao Companion is someone who has sworn to follow you for the rest of their lives." Elder Shan explained.

And before Yuan could even say anything, Meixiu opened her mouth and said in a calm voice, "I guess you can call me his Dao Companion."

"Eh?"

All of the eyes on her widened with shock and surprise. Yuan's Dao Companion?! But they couldn't sense any cultivation from her! In other words, she was a mortal! How could a mere mortal be the Dao Companion of a heaven-defying genius like Yuan?

"A-Are you really his Dao Companion? You're not joking with us here, right?" Elder Shan asked her in a trembling voice since she personally couldn't believe it.

Meixiu nodded her head and spoke in a serious voice, "I have promised to follow and serve Yuan for the rest of my life."

Unbeknownst to the people in the room, Meixiu was talking about their relationship in the real world. Of course, Meixiu herself has never heard of the term Dao Companion until today and misunderstood its meaning after hearing Elder Shan's poor explanation.

"I see... if you make it sound like that, I guess you can call her my Dao Companion." Yuan also agreed, following Meixiu's misunderstanding.

Elder Shan's jaw dropped to the floor after hearing Yuan's confirmation.

After a moment of awkward silence, Long Yijun cleared his throat before speaking, "S-Since she's your Dao Companion, I guess she can tag along."

"Thank you, Sect Master." Yuan nodded, completely oblivious to the misunderstanding that had been created from this situation.

'Looks like someone had beat you to the punch, Disciple Fei...' Elder Shan sighed inwardly, feeling a little pity for Fei Yuyan.

Elder Xuan also had similar thoughts, but he was thinking about his granddaughter, Xuan Wuhan, instead.

"Anyways, now that everyone is here, we can start making our way to the Mystic Realm." Long Yijun said.

"Disciple Yuan and his Dao Companion, Disciple Gao, Disciple Xue, Elder Xuan, Elder Shan, Elder Dai, and myself will be going to the Mystic Realm while everyone else will remain here to take care of the sect while we're gone."

Long Yijun then turned to look at Elder Bai and said, "I'll leave you in charge until we return, Elder Bai."

"I will protect the sect with my life on the line, Sect Master." Elder Bai nodded with a serious look on his face.

Sometime later, everyone that was going to the Mystic Realm gathered outside.

Once they were outside, the sect elders retrieved their flying treasures.

Elder Shan summoned her boat and Elder Xuan summoned his cloud treasure.

"Come over here, Disciple Yuan." Elder Shan patted her flying treasure.

Yuan didn't say anything and entered the boat, followed by Meixiu.

"The two of you can ride with me." Elder Xuan said to Gao Dongya and Xue Jiye.

A few moments later, once everyone was on a flying treasure, they took to the skies.

"What about the Sect Master?" Yuan asked when he noticed that they'd left him behind.

"Don't worry about him— look." Elder Shan pointed below them.

Yuan turned his head to look at the direction she was pointing, and to his surprise, there was a dragon flying towards them with Long Yijun and Elder Dai riding on its head!

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Chapter 296 - Flying Treasure

Yuan felt his heart skip a beat when he saw this dragon, and he exclaimed in an excited voice, "Is that a real dragon?!"

Even though this dragon wasn't as intimidating as the Great One, it was still an exciting sight to see a real dragon.

However, Elder Shan chuckled and said, "No, you silly. Do you remember when Elder Xuan said there are flying treasures that resemble magical beasts but aren't actually real? That dragon is one of those flying treasures. There's no way anyone would be able to tame a mighty dragon and ride them like a flying treasure."

"Is that so... but it looks so realistic," Yuan mumbled in a somewhat disappointed voice.

"You can tell whether it's real or not by its aura." Elder Shan then said.

"Oh, you're right... I cannot sense any aura coming from it." Yuan realized.

Feng Yuxiang's voice suddenly resounded in Yuan's head, "Once I am able to transform back to my phoenix form, I'll let the Young Master ride me as much as he wants! Who needs dragons when you have a phoenix! We're both Divine Beasts, anyway."

A smile appeared on Yuan's face, and he mumbled, "Thank you, Feng Feng."

Seconds later, Long Yijun caught up to them, and he said, "We're going to take the teleportation device at Bright Needle City to the Northern Continent, where the Mystic Realm will take place. It's going to take a couple of hours before we arrive at the city so you can relax until then."

"Yes, Sect Master!" They responded.

Sometime later, Elder Shan opened her mouth and spoke, "Disciple Yuan, since we have plenty of time, why don't you tell me a little more about you and your Dao Companion here? How'd you two meet?"

Yuan nodded and said, "Her parents worked for my parents, so we've known each other since we were kids."

"Oh, childhood friends, huh? What a lovely relationship already." Elder Shan chuckled.

Then she looked at Meixiu and said, "I'm very interested in what kind of woman could captivate someone like Disciple Yuan's heart. Of course, if you don't want to show your face, that's fine as well."

'Captivate Yuan's heart?' Meixiu found Elder Shan's choice of words to be weird, but she didn't think too much about it and nodded her head before removing her Crimson Mask to show Elder Shan her face.

"I see..." Elder Shan nodded her head as though she realized something, not feeling the slightest shock that Meixiu was a beauty, as it was only natural for someone as talented as Yuan to have a beauty by his side. In fact, it would be weird if Yuan's Dao Companion wasn't a beauty.

"Anyway, you're certainly one lucky lady, becoming his Dao Companion at such a young age. You have no idea how many people will be envious of you in the near future." Elder Shan said.

"T-Thank you...?" Meixiu said in a hesitant voice since she wasn't exactly sure what Elder Shan was talking about.

Sometime later, Yuan asked, "Senior Shan, since you're a Spirit Master as well, can you use Qi Manifestation?"

"Qi Manifestation? Only Spirit Grandmasters can do that!" Elder Shan quickly said.

"Really? But I heard that some Spirit Masters are able to use Qi Manifestation."

Elder Shan shook her head and said, "Maybe if they're a heaven-defying genius or have some unique physique, but under normal circumstances, one cannot use Qi Manifestation before they become a Spirit Grandmaster. Well, I can release my Qi outside to a certain extent, but that's not true Qi Manifestation."

After a moment of silence, she continued, "Well, if it's you, who can use Divine Sense before reaching Spirit Master, maybe you can use Qi Manifestation before you become a Spirit Grandmaster. Though, you'll probably still need to be around peak Spirit Master before you can do it."

"Do you want to try it now?" Elder Shan suddenly asked.

"Really? How do I try?"

Elder Shan extended her hand and said, "Now gather your spiritual energy in your hand and imagine it leaving your hand and touching my hand."

Yuan nodded and followed her instructions, lifting his hand and gathering his spiritual energy in his hand.

He then imagined it leaving his hand, almost like he'd grown a second hand.

However, he gave up a moment later when he couldn't release the spiritual energy, and it was like there was an invisible wall preventing him from doing so.

"Don't worry, if it was so easy, every Spirit Master would be able to do it." Elder Shan said to him afterward.

Yuan nodded and said, "I'm going to continue trying."

"Go ahead. Just don't exhaust yourself. Qi Manifestation also requires a lot of energy to maintain." Elder Shan said to him.

A few moments later, Xiao Hua's voice resounded inside his head, "Brother Yuan, Qi Manifestation is very similar to Divine Sense. Just practice like you would with Divine Sense."

'Now that you mention it, they are very similar!' Yuan realized this fact and immediately started trying to release his spiritual energy like he does with Divine Sense.

After an hour of practicing, Yuan finally managed to produce some results! Although it was only very slightly, he'd managed to extend his spiritual energy a few inches outside his body!

When Elder Shan saw this, her eyes widened with shock.

"D-Did you just...?" Elder Shan mumbled in a dazed voice.

"I think I am getting a hang of it." Yuan nodded.

"Unbelievable... To think you'd actually manage to release your spiritual energy outside of your body, even if it's just a little, and you'd just entered Spirit Master. I am a little ashamed of myself now..." Elder Shan sighed.

Thus, Yuan continued to practice his Qi Manifestation for the next few hours until they arrived at Bright Needle City.

However, instead of descending outside the city like one normally would, Long Yijun led them directly inside the city, only descending once they were directly above the teleportation device.

Of course, nobody complained when they saw this, and the workers there even welcomed them with bright smiles on their faces.

Chapter 297 - Mystic Realm

Gathering Spot

"Welcome to Bright Needle City, Seniors from the Dragon Essence Temple. Are you heading to the Northern Continent for the Mystic Realm?" The worker there immediately recognized their identity and even their destination at a glance since he was warned beforehand.

"Yes, we are." Long Yijun nodded his head.

Sometime later, after paying the worker the bill in spirit stones, Long Yijun and the others walked through the teleportation device.

"Are you okay?" Yuan asked Meixiu after noticing the discomfort on her face.

"Yes... Just a little dizzy." Meixiu said.

"That's what happens when mortals use teleportation devices. Don't worry, it's nothing serious and will go away after some time." Elder Shan said to them.

A few moments later, they returned to the skies on their flying treasure.

"We'll arrive at the location in three hours." Long Yijun said to them in the air.

"By the way, I have been wondering, but how many sects will be participating in the Mystic Realm?" Yuan suddenly asked them.

"Well, it's different every time, but there will always be over 100 sects." Elder Shan said, and she continued, "And out of these sects, only 100 of

them will enter the sect ranking and become an elite sect, and our Dragon Essence Temple ranked 7th during the last Mystic Realm."

"If I remember correctly, the slots for each sect are distributed depending on their previous results. How will new sects obtain these spots if they didn't participate previously?" Yuan then asked.

"In the case that a new sect wants to participate in the Mystic Realm, there are a few ways they can obtain a slot, whether it be earning them through important events or even straight-up buying them with money, which most of them do. Of course, they can only obtain one slot maximum no matter how they obtained it."

"Over 100 sects, huh? That's a lot of people. What benefits does being an elite sect bring besides recognition?" Yuan then asked.

"Nothing, really. However, recognition and fame are the most important factors for sects since that's what attracts new disciples. Even though the difference between rank 7 and rank 6 may not seem very much in your eyes, it's actually very vast, especially since that might be the deciding factor for someone looking for a new sect."

"I see..." Yuan nodded.

About an hour later, their scenery suddenly changed drastically, going from a world rich with trees and greenery to a barren world that barely had any healthy-looking trees, and the further they went, the more desolate the place looked.

"Where are we?" Yuan couldn't help but ask, feeling an ominous feeling coming from this place.

"This is the 'Desolate Land', a unique place that takes up one-third of the entire Northern Continent." Elder Shan explained.

"Did something happen in this place that caused this atmosphere?" Yuan continued to ask.

"Legend has it that a fight had occurred in this place."

"A fight...?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

Elder Shan nodded, "That's right. Not a war— a fight between two cultivators."

"Good lord... two people caused this? Is that even possible?" Yuan's eyes widened with surprise.

"Yes, but this happened in the ancient times when there were no restrictions between each of the heavens and Immortals were free to roam from heaven to heaven with little to no effort. Perhaps what happened in this place is the reason the mighty Heavens placed the restrictions on us in the first place— at least if the legend was true."

"Is that so..." Yuan mumbled before turning to watch the scenery again.

Although there was nothing to see, the barren world itself was a spectacle for Yuan, who has never seen such a view before.

A few more hours later, Long Yijun said to them, "We're almost there. Prepare yourselves."

"W-What is that thing in the distance?" Yuan suddenly asked, his voice sounding a little shocked.

Meixiu narrowed her eyes, and she could see some sort of chasm in the distance, almost like a pair of gates opened slightly.

"That's the gates to the Mystic Realm. Quite big, right?" Elder Shan chuckled at his reaction.

"Big is an understatement, Senior Shan. That thing is massive! Is that a treasure? How did they move that thing? Or has it always been there?" Yuan expressed his awe.

"Yes, it's a treasure, and no, they cannot move it." Elder Shan explained.

A few minutes later, the already large gates appeared even larger, making anyone who was in its presence feel like mere ants.

"We're here." Long Yijun said about ten minutes later.

Once they stopped flying in the air, Yuan and everyone else looked down at the area, and to their surprise, there were houses built on the ground along with some camps and a couple of hundred people.

"We're landing." Long Yijun said before descending his flying treasure.

Yuan and the others could feel numerous gazes suddenly directed in their direction.

"Ignore them." Elder Xuan said.

Once they landed, Long Yijun retrieved his flying treasure which turned into a toy-like object that resembled a dragon. He then pulled out another toy-like object from his spatial ring, which resembled a house this time.

Long Yijun poured his spiritual energy into this toy house before throwing it at the empty lot in front of them.

Poof!

The palm-sized toy house suddenly expanded until it was the size of a real building, leaving Yuan speechless and Meixiu full of surprise.

"Quickly, go inside." Long Yijun said to them in a hasty voice, sounding as though they were in immediate danger.

Yuan and the other didn't dare to linger and immediately went inside this building that was already filled with decoration.

However, while the disciples went inside, Long Yijun and the sect elders remained standing outside while facing a certain direction, almost like they were waiting for something.

And a few seconds later, they could see many figures approaching their direction, all of them emitting powerful auras belonging to Spirit Masters with even one of them being a mighty Spirit Grandmaster!

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Chapter 298 - Jealousy

"It's been a while, fellow Daoists." Long Yijun greeted the guests with a friendly smile on his face while the three elders stood behind him with vigilant looks on their faces.

Even though these guests all had friendly-looking expressions on their faces, one can never be too careful in the cultivation world where anything can happen, especially when they are competitors.

"Sect Master Long and sect elders, it's been ten long years since our last meeting."

"You arrived almost at the last minute this time, Sect Master Long. Did something happen? The Dragon Essence Temple is usually always the first ones to arrive."

"Don't tell me you almost forgot about the Mystic Realm?"

These guests were all Sect Masters and high-ranking elders from the other sects, their intentions unclear.

"I guess you can say something like that." Long Yijun responded in a calm voice.

"By the way, I heard the Dragon Essence Temple managed to win a major bet recently that earned them a few Divine-grade treasures. Congratulations." One of them suddenly spoke, mentioning the gamble Long Yijun made with the other sects.

"Hahaha! Thank you! Indeed, my Dragon Essence Temple managed to amass a small fortune due to some minor luck! However, my sect doesn't really need these treasures, so if you would like to buy them, give the

Dragon Essence Temple a visit after the Mystic Realm! I will even give you a discount!" Long Yijun said, still with an innocent-looking smile on his face.

The Sect Masters there stared at Long Yijun with dumbfounded looks on their faces, as they didn't expect him to suddenly start selling the Divine-grade treasures he'd obviously tricked from the others! What a shameless fellow, they all thought!

"A-Anyways, I have been wondering for a while now but I only saw two disciples from your group. I thought the Dragon Essence Temple obtained 3 slots from the last Mystic Realm?" The Spirit Grandmaster there suddenly asked.

The two disciples he was referring to were Xue Jiye and Gao Dongya. As for Meixiu, there was no way they'd let a mortal who hasn't even begun to cultivate enter the Mystic Realm. Meanwhile, in his eyes, Yuan, who was emitting the aura of a Spirit Master— it was impossible for someone like that to be a mere disciple.

In fact, everybody there thought the same and mistook Yuan as another sect elder from the Dragon Essence Temple.

Long Yijun realized this fact and took advantage of their misunderstanding and said with an arrogant-looking smug face, "The Dragon Essence Temple is so confident this year that we'd decided to only use two out of our three slots."

"What?! Are you insane?!"

The Sect Masters there were shocked speechless by Long Yijun's claims.

So confident in his two disciples that they'd be willing to give up an entire spot?! Not even the number one sect would do such a foolish thing! After all, every additional spot in the Mystic Realm could be the difference between rank one and rank 10!

Furthermore, they have already done their research on Xue Jiye and Gao Dongya even before they became Core Disciples! While they are, without doubt, among the top geniuses in the Lower Heavens, they don't show any heaven-defying talents that would shake the entire world, and the other sects also have similar talents, hence why the Sect Masters couldn't understand where Long Yijun's confidence was coming from.

After talking with each other for a few more minutes, the people from the other sects left Long Yijun and the others alone, yet they felt as though something was amiss.

"Let's go inside as well." Long Yijun said to the sect elders afterward.

Once they were inside the building, Long Yijun burst out laughing, "Hahahaha! These idiots really believed me! They really thought I would give up such a valuable spot over arrogance!"

Yuan and the other disciples watched him laugh with raised eyebrows.

After laughing for some time, Long Yijun said, "Anyways, you guys can relax until the Mystic Realm starts in two days. There are plenty of rooms in this building so pick whichever one you want. The sect elders and I will keep watch until then."

Sometime later, Meixiu said to Yuan, "It's getting late so I'll log off first to prepare dinner."

Yuan nodded, "I'll also log off in a bit. I want to practice Qi Manifestation for a little longer."

After logging off the game, Meixiu went to prepare dinner.

While dinner was cooking, Meixiu went to check on the Frozen Jade Zither's auction.

[Time until auction ends: 6 days 10 hours]

[Current Bid: 410,000,000]

"400 million already, huh? At this rate, it will definitely reach half a billion."

Although the auction has slowed down, Meixiu had no doubt that it would reach at least 500 million.

A few minutes later, Meixiu could hear her phone ringing, and to her surprise, it was from her mother.

"Hello," Meixiu answered the phone after taking a deep breath.

"Meixiu, I have spoken with the Yu Family and notified them of your leave." Meifeng's voice resounded a few seconds later.

And she continued, "They were definitely not happy about it, especially since you're my daughter and the Young Lady's personal maid. However, there was nothing they could do about it since you're not bound to a contract like I am since you're still not old enough to legally sign any contracts. If you had been even a few months late, you would've been stuck with the Yu Family for essentially the rest of your life, so consider yourself lucky."

"I see... Thank you... mother..." Meixiu said to her after hearing this news.

"Don't thank me, Meixiu. I didn't do this for you. Everything is for the Young Master." Meifeng said.

After a moment of silence, Meifeng suddenly said, "Meixiu... To tell you the truth, I am very envious of you, who can stay by the Young Master's side, whilst I can only watch him from a distance. Therefore, if you don't treat the Young Master properly, I won't forgive you. Do you hear me?"

"I hear you..." Meixiu responded in a somewhat dazed voice.

Chapter 299 - Rebellious Stage

"Good. Then I'll be leaving now." Meifeng said to Meixiu before cutting the phone call.

"Haaa..." Meifeng released a long and deep breath afterward, rubbing her eyes in a tired manner.

A few moments later, Meifeng turned around and entered the room that was right behind her with a serious-looking expression on her face.

Inside the room, there were two individuals sitting across from each other on a small but fancy table filled with luxurious food and a couple of servants standing at the end of the room.

"What did Meixiu say? Did you manage to convince her to stay?" Yu Yong asked her the moment she returned.

Meifeng shook her head and said, "Unfortunately, she wouldn't listen to me no matter how much I tried to convince her, even cutting the line on me forcibly when I tried. I will take full responsibility for my daughter's sudden departure, Masters."

Yu Yong placed his utensils down before sighing, "Don't worry about it, Meifeng. It's not your fault. Meixiu is probably in her rebellious stage since she's around that age. Once she gets over it, she will definitely return to us so let's just give her more time."

"Thank you, Master Yu." Meifeng bowed to him.

Obviously, it was only an excuse that Meifeng had created for Meixiu, as she'd told the Yu Family that Meixiu was tired of working and decided to leave.

"Anyway, how is the auction looking for the Divine-grade treasure?" Tang Lee suddenly asked.

"Allow me a moment to check," Meifeng said as she pulled out her phone.

After checking the auction, Meifeng said, "The highest bid right now is 411 million dollars; it'd increased by 21 million since we last checked half an hour ago."

"I see... Do you have any predictions on how much it might cost by the end?" Tang Lee then asked.

"It's hard to tell since this is the first time a Divine-grade treasure has been sold. Furthermore, it is highly likely that this treasure belongs to Player Yuan. With that being said, the price most likely won't see any more significant increases since this treasure is only an instrument, and its high requirements restrict most if not all of the players at this moment, so most of the other families have already stepped back." Meifeng said.

Yu Yong nodded and said, "While it's true that the treasure has a high requirement, this is an investment for the future! Once we have someone who can use that zither, everything will change and we will overtake the other families!"

"Continue monitoring the auction. We'll stop bidding for now until the last day."

"Yes, Master Yu."

Meanwhile, after dinner was prepared, Meixiu went to feed Yuan four bowls of soup as instructed by Doctor Wang.

A few minutes after dinner, almost as though she knew, Yu Rou called Meixiu— or more specifically, Yuan.

"How was your day, brother? I saw the auction! It's a massive success! Over 400 million dollars in a single day— you'll definitely get at least 500

million from the auction!" Yu Rou's excited voice resounded in his ears, making it feel as though Yu Rou was really in the room.

"At this rate, you won't have to worry about not having enough money for the rest of your life!"

"Indeed," Yuan said.

"By the way, do you see other players at the Mystic Realm?" Yu Rou suddenly asked.

"No, I just got there myself."

"I see... Well, good luck, brother! Although I will be going back to school tomorrow, I had a lot of fun with Xia Jingyi. We did many quests together, even hunting a dozen magical beasts. Of course, I was the one who slew them all!" Yu Rou spoke in a proud voice.

"That sounds fun," Yuan said with a smile on his face.

"It is! You should come play with us once you're done with the Mystic Realm."

"That's what I plan on doing— oh, wait. I still have one more thing to do before the Mystic Realm."

"Take your time, brother. We have plenty of time to play the game together." Yu Rou said.

"Anyway, I will talk to you later. I'm going to sleep now. Goodnight, brother. Goodnight, Meixiu."

"Goodnight, Yu Rou."

"Goodnight, Sister Rou."

After the phone call ended, Meixiu returned to her own room to sleep whilst Yuan cultivated.

The following morning, after breakfast, they returned to Cultivation Online.

"Good morning, everybody." Yuan greeted them.

"Did you have a good rest last night? The Mystic Realm won't start until sunrise tomorrow but there will be a gathering later today since all of the participating sects have arrived." Elder Xuan said to him.

Yuan nodded, then he asked, "By the way, I have been wondering, but do you think I can take a closer look at the gates to the Mystic Realm? Or would that be too dangerous?"

"Well, besides some roaming magical beasts in this area, there's really not much danger. And with so many peak experts in this place, even a Spirit Grandmaster magical beast won't be able to do a thing, so you don't have to worry about them." Elder Xuan explained.

Long Yijun interrupted, "It's not the magical beasts we're worried about—it's the other sects. While it's very unlikely that anybody would start a fight here, it's not impossible, and it has happened before."

"Even if we may act friendly to one another, it's all just a public act. Don't forget, we're all competitors fighting for the next highest rank."

"However, if you want to look at the gates, I won't say no. Just make sure you're with one of the sect elders." Long Yijun said.

"I will come with you." Elder Xuan said, and he continued, "And before you leave, change into these clothes."

Yuan accepted the clothes that resembled what sect elders would wear.

"The others think you're a sect elder because of your cultivation base. It would be in our best interest to keep them thinking that until the start of the Mystic Realm." Elder Xuan said.

"Okay. Do you want to come with us, Meixiu?" Yuan asked her.

Meixiu silently nodded her head.

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Chapter 300 - Taking A Closer Look At The Mystic Realm

"I-I also want to come!" Xue Jiye suddenly said, and she continued, "It's my first time coming to this place, and it's probably going to be my last, so I want to make it more memorable!"

Elder Xuan nodded, "Okay."

A few moments later, Yuan went to the other room to change his clothes, wearing the sect elder's uniform given to him by Elder Xuan.

"Wow, you look much better in those clothes than I'd anticipated. You'll definitely be a popular sect elder if you become one, especially among the female disciples." Elder Shan's eyes widened with surprise when she saw Yuan wearing the sect elder's uniform, which gave him a more profound feeling and also enhanced his handsome appearance by a level.

Even Xue Jiye couldn't help but swallow nervously after seeing Yuan's new appearance.

After another moment, Yuan and Meixiu wore their masks before going outside with Elder Xuan, making their way towards the Mystic Realm that was only a couple of miles in the distance.

Since the place was an empty and flat land and the gates were massive, the Mystic Realm looked much closer than reality, and when they approached the gates, it felt like they weren't getting any closer despite walking towards it for many minutes.

About half an hour later, they could see a large group of people gathered in the front, all staring at the Mystic Realm with awe on their faces.

"Looks like we're not the only ones who wanted to look at the Mystic Realm." Xue Jiye mumbled as they approached this group.

The people there turned to look at them when they noticed their presence.

"The Dragon Essence Temple, huh?"

However, they didn't pay too much attention to them and returned to looking at the Mystic Realm that was emitting an otherworldly light, almost like it would lead them to another world if they entered the light.

Meanwhile, Yuan was wondering if there were any players among these people, as they all looked relatively similar to each other in terms of appearance and the aura they gave off.

"Wow, this treasure is even more massive than I thought..." Yuan mumbled in a dazed voice as he tilted his head to look at the giant gate that pierced the clouds in the sky.

There were also these complex symbols on each side of this gate, giving the place a more mystical feeling to it.

Almost as though they were captivated by it, Yuan and the others stared at this gate with dazed looks on their faces for many minutes without blinking.

Suddenly, unbeknownst to the others there, a voice resounded from beyond the Mystic Realm that only reached Yuan's ears, and it was an ancient-sounding voice, almost as though it was beckoning him.

'Alas...'

'I have...'

'Been...'

'Waiting...'

'For you...'

Yuan's eyes widened when he noticed a semi-transparent figure hovering directly between the gates, almost like a hologram of sorts.

However, this person didn't have a face. It had long black hair that flapped behind him like a cape, and it was wearing black clothes with gold outlines around the clothes, giving this individual a majestic atmosphere, almost like he was royalty.

When Yuan saw this faceless individual, his blood began boiling for some reason, and it was unclear whether the reaction was due to excitement or something else entirely.

"Who... are you?" Yuan mumbled in a mosquito-like voice.

Even though this individual hovering in front of the Mystic Realm lacked any facial features, Yuan could somehow tell that it was looking directly at him.

'Come...'

'Here...'

This ancient voice continued to beckon Yuan.

After an unknown amount of time had passed, Yuan suddenly felt someone pat his shoulders.

"Are you okay?" Elder Xuan asked him.

"Eh? What do you mean?"

"I have been calling you for a while now, but you were absorbed in the Mystic Realm, not noticing it."

"Oh, I'm sorry. I was a little too focused on that figure floating in front of the gates. Who is that person?" Yuan said.

"Huh? Figure? What are you talking about? There's nobody there." Elder Xuan looked at him with a surprised expression.

Elder Xuan then turned to look at the gates just in case, but as he'd expected, there wasn't anybody there.

"Are you sure you saw somebody there? One cannot approach the Mystic Realm without the tokens, hence why we aren't getting any closer than this, and we won't be getting these tokens until later today." Elder Xuan explained to him.

"Yes, I'm sure," Yuan said, and he proceeded to describe the faceless man to Elder Xuan.

"Hmm... As far as I'm aware, nobody has seen this faceless individual before since I have never heard of this person until today. We can ask the Sect Master later, but we should get back for now since the gathering will happen soon."

"Okay." Yuan nodded, following Elder Xuan and the others back to their building.

'Come...'

'Here...'

The voice continued to resound inside Yuan's head even as he left the place.

However, when he turned around, that faceless individual was no longer there, and the voice disappeared shortly after as well.

Once they returned to their building, Elder Xuan explained the situation to Long Yijun.

"Interesting... A faceless individual..." Long Yijun pondered with a serious look on his face.

"Do you know something about this, Sect Master?" Elder Xuan asked.

After a moment of silence, Long Yijun shook his head and said, "While I have heard of numerous phenomena occurring around the Mystic Realm before, I don't recall anything about a faceless person. I can ask around later, but don't expect an answer."

"I see..." Yuan nodded.

"Anyways, the gathering won't happen for another two hours, but we should start heading there now or else it will look bad for the Dragon Essence Temple if the envoys from the Spirit Heaven arrive before us."

"Envoys from the upper heavens? Does this mean people from this Spirit Heaven will come down here?" Yuan asked.

Long Yijun laughed and said, "Of course not, silly. It takes too much effort and resources to come down here. Even if they're incredibly rich, they won't be able to afford coming down here every decade!"

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Chapter 301 - The Aura Of A Spirit King

"Is that so... What a pity. I wanted to see someone from the Spirit Heaven." Yuan sighed.

Long Yijun chuckled at his words and said, "Besides having a much higher cultivation base and being more knowledgeable because of their larger world, there's really not much difference between us. It's not as if people from the upper heavens are different entities."

"I see... that makes sense." Yuan nodded.

"Anyways, let's get moving. The other sects are already gathering at the location."

The Dragon Essence Temple left the building and followed the other sects to the gathering area that was just a few miles away from their lodging location.

Sometime later, they arrived at the gathering area, where over a hundred sects gathered and stood separated from each other but in an orderly fashion, almost like a massive military formation getting ready for war.

The Dragon Essence Temple stood at the very front of this massive formation. Despite the fact that many sects had arrived before them, there was an empty spot in the front with other sects occupying the spots behind it, almost like it was left empty specifically for the Dragon Essence Temple.

Each sect had around five to ten people with them, but there were also sects that brought over a hundred people, mostly for spectating.

While everybody there waited for this envoy from the Spirit Heaven to show up, Yuan turned to look at the Mystic Realm that was in the distance, hoping to see the faceless figure again.

'Xiao Hua, Feng Feng, was it just me, or did you two also see that faceless figure?' Yuan decided to ask the two experts dwelling inside his body.

'Xiao Hua didn't see anyone like that.'

'Me neither, Young Master. Are you sure you weren't seeing things?'

'I'm sure. It was even calling for me... I don't know why, but I felt somewhat nostalgic when I saw this faceless figure, almost like I'd seen it before, but that's impossible. Maybe I'm just overthinking things,' Yuan sighed inwardly.

Suddenly, Xiao Hua said in a serious voice, 'Brother Yuan, be careful. There are a lot of people looking in our direction right now. Although I cannot say for certain that they're looking at you, it's very likely.'

Hearing Xiao Hua's words, Yuan realized why he was feeling uncomfortable for some time now. So it was caused by these stares.

'The Dragon Essence Temple is quite popular, after all. I wouldn't be surprised if they were staring at us.' Yuan said.

'While that is true, the looks they're giving are different from that of awe or admiration, and they look more like they're trying to see through your mask, Young Master.' Feng Feng added.

Yuan's body shuddered after hearing these words, and he wondered to himself, 'It couldn't be the other players, right?'

Indeed, these people staring at Yuan were all players that were chosen to participate in the Mystic Realm. While their cultivation bases are nothing exaggerated like Yuan, who was a Spirit Master, they all show promising talents, not to mention their Heaven-rank physiques.

Although the Sect Masters and Sect Elders all mistook Yuan as a Sect Elder because of his Spirit Master cultivation base, the players were not fooled by his cultivation, mostly because Player Yuan was famous for his black mask ever since the zither competition, and everybody knew that he was in the Dragon Essence Temple, hence why they expected him to show up at the Mystic Realm.

And just as the players had expected, Player Yuan showed up.

'So that's the famous Player Yuan, huh? Even though I cannot see his cultivation base, he gives off the same feeling as our Sect Master—the same domineering aura.' One of the players there thought inwardly.

'Player Yuan... Just you wait! If we ever meet in the Mystic Realm, I am going to rip that mask off your face and reveal your identity to the world!' Another one thought.

'Player Yuan... I wonder what he looks like underneath that black mask...'

Sometime later, the atmosphere in the place began to change, and although it was a subtle change at first, all of the Sect Masters there noticed it.

Upon feeling this change, they all said to their disciples, "The envoy is coming! Stand straight and don't utter a single sound unless you're told to speak!"

The entire place immediately turned dead silent, and everyone there waited nervously for this 'envoy' to show up.

Whoosh!

The wind suddenly picked up, and a massive portal appeared above the sects, shocking the Sect Masters.

"W-Wait! What's happening?!"

"T-This is! Somebody from the upper heavens is trying to come down to the Lower Heavens?! Did they send an envoy to personally oversee the Mystic Realm this time?!"

Usually, the experts from Spirit Heaven would just use some sort of treasure to speak with them from above, and rarely would they come down to the Lower Heavens in person. In fact, the last time a real envoy showed up in the Lower Heavens for the Mystic Realm was over 10,000 years ago!

Perhaps this is what the rumors actually meant? That a real envoy would be showing up?

The spiritual energy in the area started acting up and began rushing towards the portal in the sky.

A domineering aura appeared moments later, and it was something nobody there— not even the Sect Masters, have experienced before.

However, two people recognized this kind of aura.

Feng Yuxiang, who had experienced it herself not long ago when she first met Yuan.

And Xiao Hua, who could emit the same aura herself— the aura of a Spirit King!

"Young Master, it's a Spirit King! A Spirit King is descending!" Feng Yuxiang said to him in an excited voice.

"What? The same level as Xiao Hua?" Yuan was surprised to hear this since this is his first time seeing another cultivator at the same level as Xiao Hua ever since he started playing the game.

After a few more moments of suspense and tension, Yuan and the others could see a figure coming out of the portal— an old man wearing black and red robes.

Chapter 302 - Once

"Welcome to the Lower Heavens, Senior Envoy!"

The Sect Masters and experts there all bowed to this old man in black clothes after he descended.

This old man swept the crowd with a calm gaze before nodding his head and speaking in a nonchalant voice, "My surname is Nie. You can simply address me as Senior Nie, and I am from the Nine Array Academy, one of the seven Spirit Academies within the Spirit Heaven."

Despite speaking in a calm tone, his voice sounded very clear for everyone there, almost like he was standing directly in front of them.

"I was sent down here to the Lower Heavens for one... No, two purposes. First and foremost, I will be overseeing the Mystic Realm, and secondly, I am looking for potential talents to bring to the Spirit Heaven with me."

"WHAT?!"

The people there expressed immense shock after hearing Senior Nie's words.

Senior Nie continued to speak, ignoring the peoples' shocked reaction, "However, I can only bring a very limited number of people with me. Three people to be exact. Therefore, I will select the participants with the most potential and best results in the Mystic Realm to come with me."

"If you manage to get selected, you'll also have a chance to become a disciple at one of the seven Spirit Academies, and depending on your potential, you might even become an Inner Disciple straight away."

"The seven Spirit Academies are the most prestigious and influential sects in the Spirit Heaven with countless resources and heavenly techniques. Countless cultivators dream of becoming a disciple at one of these seven sects, but one must go through rigorous tests before they are accepted as a disciple. However, you will get to bypass such tests and become a disciple immediately if you're chosen."

The disciples there trembled with excitement after hearing Senior Nie's words. If they are chosen to go to the Spirit Heaven with Senior Nie, their future will surely be a successful one! This was a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity!

As for the Sect Masters and Sect Elders there, while they were happy for their disciples for getting such a grand opportunity, they were also quite jealous of the disciples since most of them dream of ascending to the Spirit Heaven as well.

Meanwhile, the players there were even more excited.

'If I get to ascend to the Spirit Heaven before I reach Spirit Grandmaster, I will immediately be ahead of every player in the Lower Heavens, and there's even a good chance that I could surpass the seemingly unrivaled Player Yuan!'

The players thought to themselves.

"Now that I've introduced myself, allow me to tell you about the Mystic Realm." Senior Nie said.

After taking a deep breath, he continued, "Let's talk about the rules of the Mystic Realm."

"With that being said, these rules are mostly rules set by the Mystic Realm and they are not something I—or anyone for that matter—have control over. You can consider it as the rules of that world."

"Anyways, first and foremost, your cultivation base will not matter in the Mystic Realm. Once you enter the gates to the Mystic Realm, your

cultivation base will be wiped, and you'll have to start from scratch. However, this is only temporary since your cultivation base will return once you come back out. Furthermore, any spiritual energy you obtain whilst inside the Mystic Realm will affect your real cultivation base, so you'll even see an increase in your cultivation afterward depending on how much you earned inside."

After giving the people a few moments to digest the information, Senior Nie continued, "Next! Treasures are not allowed inside the Mystic Realm! If you have anything that isn't a part of your body, you'll be rejected by the Mystic Realm until you get rid of those treasures!"

"As for the third rule which is related to the second rule, just like treasures, you're not allowed to bring your magical beasts into the Mystic Realm since they are considered as their own entity! Of course, you can bring your magical beast inside if you give it a token! However, that will take away one precious spot, so you'll have to consider if that's worth it or not!"

Yuan raised his eyebrows when he heard this. What about Xiao Hua and Feng Yuxiang? Does this mean they'll have to stay out here while he goes inside?

'Looks like we won't be able to follow you inside the Mystic Realm, Young Master.' Feng Feng suddenly said to him.

"Unless we take the two disciples' spot from them...' she added.

However, before Yuan could say anything, Senior Nie continued, "Furthermore, only those who are below the age of 30 are allowed to enter the Mystic Realm! As for those who have magical beasts as servants, the magical beast must be younger than 100 years old!"

'100 years old... I guess I won't be able to go in after all...' Feng Yuxiang sighed.

'What about you, Xiao Hua? You're human, so you should be able to enter... Unless you're over thirty...' Feng Yuxiang said to her.

"..."

However, Xiao Hua didn't respond to her and remained silent.

'It's okay, you two. Even if you can go inside with me, I cannot take away the others' spots. They earned it, and it'd be incredibly rude of us if we stole it.' Yuan said to them.

'I knew that, Young Master. I was only joking with you.'

"The next rule— once you enter the Mystic Realm, you have 30 days to show results and obtain points. You can obtain points by increasing your cultivation, slaying magical beasts, finding treasures, clearing trials, and many more methods. If you manage to obtain a certain amount of points, you will be able to enter the Mystic Pagoda somewhere inside the Mystic Realm. As for what's inside the Mystic Pagoda... I cannot tell you— nobody can. Why? Because nobody has managed to enter the Mystic Pagoda before." Senior Nie said.

And he continued with a subtle smile on his face, "If you manage to enter the Mystic Pagoda, you're guaranteed to come to the Spirit Heavens with me so keep that in mind."

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Chapter 303 - Distributing The Tokens

"Now let's talk about your safety in the Mystic Realm— although you won't outright die if you die inside the Mystic Realm, there's a chance that it might affect your cultivation once you leave the place so don't take death lightly inside just because you won't die for real." Senior Nie continued to speak.

"If you happen to die inside the Mystic Realm, you will immediately be teleported out of the Mystic Realm, and you won't be able to enter for a second time since every individual can only enter the Mystic Realm once in their lifetime."

"That's all I have for now— does any of the Sect Masters here have any questions for me before I hand out the tokens?" Senior Nie swept the crowd with a calm gaze.

The place remained silent. Although all of the Sect Masters had questions inside their heads, it was not related to the Mystic Realm that they've seen many times before, and it might offend Senior Nie if they brought it up in their current situation.

"Then I shall begin handing out the tokens now."

After taking a deep breath, Senior Nie spoke, "Ranked first, Heaven and Earth Palace, 7 tokens."

"Heaven and Earth Palace is present, Senior Nie!"

The Sect Master of the Heaven and Earth Palace responded loudly.

Senior Nie then tossed seven square-shaped tokens made of a blue material that resembled jade at the Sect Master of the Heaven and Earth Palace.

After accepting the tokens, the Sect Master bowed in a respectful manner, "Received! Thank you, Senior Nie!"

Senior Nie nodded his head before continuing, "Ranked second, Grand Sword Mountain, 6 tokens."

"Grand Sword Mountain is present, Senior Nie!"

The Sect Master of the place responded, and Senior Nie handed them 6 tokens.

"Ranked third, Flaming Fists Sect, 5 tokens."

"Flaming Fist Sect is present, Senior Nie!"

"Ranked fourth, Azure Phoenix Sect, 4 tokens."

"Ranked fifth, Purple Lotus Fairy Garden, 3 tokens."

"Ranked sixth, Frozen Blade Academy, 3 tokens."

"Ranked seventh, Dragon Essence Temple, 3 tokens."

"Ranked eighth, Three Poisons Manor, 2 tokens."

"Ranked ninth, Heavenly Totem Sect, 2 tokens."

"Ranked tenth, Diamond Palms Sect, 2 tokens."

After naming the top ten sects, Senior Nie said, "The rest of you will be getting one token each."

He then tossed over a hundred tokens down, each flying to one of the Sect Masters there.

In total, there were 150 tokens handed out by Senior Nie, meaning there will only be 150 participants entering the Mystic Realm.

"The Mystic Realm will open at sunrise tomorrow, and I won't be back until then." After saying those words, Senior Nie flew away and quickly disappeared from the scene, almost like he was in a hurry to go somewhere.

Once Senior Nie's presence was completely gone, everybody there sighed in relief, feeling as though a large amount of pressure had just been lifted from their bodies.

When they were certain that Senior Nie would not suddenly return, the massive formation began breaking apart and the sects returned to their own lodging.

"Let's also return." Long Yijun said to them.

Yuan and the others nodded and followed Long Yijun back to the building.

However, before they could reach the building, someone suddenly called out loud, "Player Yuan!"

Yuan's body subconsciously stopped walking and turned around after hearing his name being called out by an unfamiliar-sounding voice.

When he turned around, there was a handsome young man with short black hair and a cold face standing behind him, looking to be in his mid-twenties.

"Remember my name— Lightning Emperor! I don't care who you are but I will surpass you soon! Just you wait!" This player who is renowned around the world as one of the current top players said with a serious look on his face.

However, before Yuan could even respond, Lightning Emperor turned around and walked away.

'Lightning Emperor? Why does his name sound so familiar?' Yuan wondered.

Then he remembered.

'Oh, right! Yu Rou mentioned him once before— that top player who had the highest cultivation base.'

Yuan narrowed his eyes at Lightning Emperor and looked at his cultivation base.

'Sixth level Spirit Warrior, huh.'

"Did you know that disciple from the Grand Sword Mountain?" Long Yijun asked him.

"Not really." Yuan shook his head, and they began walking again shortly after.

However, another player called out to Yuan after a few steps.

"Player Yuan! If you dare, show me the face behind that mask!"

This player outright asked Yuan to reveal his identity in a shameless voice.

Yuan looked at this goofy-looking young man for a moment before he continued walking, completely ignoring the player.

"Hey! Where do you think you're going—"

The player tried to approach Yuan, but alas, Elder Xuan stepped between them and said, "If you wish to speak with our disciples, you should bring your Sect Master with you."

The player swallowed nervously upon feeling Elder Xuan's invisible pressure, and he decided to turn around and run away.

"I'll do whatever it takes to see your face, Player Yuan! See ya in the Mystic Realm! Hahaha!" The player laughed out loud as he disappeared into the distance.

"You sure have a lot of friends, Disciple Yuan." Elder Xuan said to him afterward.

"If only that was the case..." Yuan sighed.

A few more players tried to approach Yuan after the last person, but before they could get close, Elder Xuan would always stand in their path and block them, and not wanting to be outdone by Elder Xuan, Elder Shan also did the same, even fighting him to block the other players.

"Player Yuan! Please shake my hands!"

Another voice resounded, this time from a female player.

"Please stay away. Our disciples do not wish to speak with any guests right now." Elder Shan immediately blocked this female player.

However, Yuan stopped walking and turned around, thinking to himself, 'This voice... It sounds so familiar...'

When Yuan turned around and finally saw the face of this female player, his eyes widened, and he nearly blurted out her name in surprise.

'Wang Xiuying! What's she doing here?'

Indeed, this person was Wang Xiuying, Doctor Wang's granddaughter!

Chapter 304 - Handshake

"I see... Sorry to bother you..." Wang Xiuying sighed after being told off by Elder Shan, and she turned around with a dejected look on her face.

However, a stiff voice suddenly resounded, halting her steps.

"Wait."

"Huh?" Wang Xiuying turned around, and to her surprise, Yuan was looking at her, even walking in her direction.

"D-Disciple Yuan?" Elder Shan looked at him with wide eyes. He ignored all of the male cultivators when they tried to approach him, but when it came to a pretty young lady approaching him, he didn't mind it, even responding to her?

A few moments later, Yuan stood in front of the speechless Wang Xiuying.

He then extended his hand, almost like he was asking for a handshake.

Wang Xiuying stared at Yuan's hands in a dazed manner, her eyes filled with disbelief.

"You wanted a handshake, right?" Yuan asked her in a low voice so she won't easily recognize him, snapping her out of her daze.

"Y-Yes! Sorry for the delay!" Wang Xiuying nodded her head before she quickly reached for Yuan's hands, giving him a firm handshake.

'What a pair of beautiful and clear eyes— it reminds me of someone...'
Wang Xiuying thought to herself when she looked at Yuan's bright eyes

through the holes in the mask, feeling nostalgic for some reason, almost like she'd seen them before.

"Umm..."

Despite shaking hands for longer than one normally would, Wang Xiuying didn't remove her hands from Yuan, almost like she'd forgotten about it after seeing his eyes.

"Oh! Sorry!" Wang Xiuying hastily released her grasp once she realized the situation.

"Anyways, I am Healer Wang, and I'm from the Medicine Valley. It's an honor to finally meet you, Player Yuan! Thank you for shaking my hands, and good luck in the Mystic Realm!" Wang Xiuying gave Yuan her nickname, completely unaware that Yuan already knew her real identity.

'Healer Wang...?' Yuan raised his eyebrows at her name but he didn't say anything, merely nodding in silence.

Once Wang Xiuying left, Yuan returned to the others.

"Yuan, that girl was Doctor Wang's..." Meixiu also recognized Wang Xiuying since she visits Doctor Wang's hospital often with Yu Rou.

"Yes, it was Wang Xiuying," Yuan confirmed. "Just like you, she looked almost like she did when she was young, so I immediately knew it was her."

"So you knew her?" Elder Shan said.

Yuan nodded, "Yes, she's a good friend of mine."

Elder Shan became even more confused after hearing such words since it looked the complete opposite just now, almost like it was their first meeting, especially since Wang Xiuying didn't appear to know him.

Sometime later, they returned to their lodging.

Inside, Yuan spoke, "Since I cannot bring treasures inside, I won't be able to hide my face... Are there any methods to get around this?"

Long Yijun then said, "That's simple— you can just wear an ordinary mask inside."

"I see..."

"I can go buy one right now." Elder Xuan said.

"Thank you for your trouble," Yuan said to him.

Elder Xuan left the place shortly after to buy some masks for Yuan.

Long Yijun said afterward, "Here are the tokens for the Mystic Realm. Don't lose them or you won't be able to enter the Mystic Realm."

He then handed a blue token to each of the participants.

"As for your treasures, you can hand them to me now or before you enter the Mystic Realm tomorrow. I'll hold onto them for you." Long Yijun then said.

Gao Dongya and Xue Jiye handed their spatial rings and storage pouches to Long Yijun a moment later.

"What about you, Disciple Yuan? I can hold onto them for you, or you can let your Dao Companion hold it for you." Long Yijun asked him afterward.

'Xiao Hua will hold onto your treasures for you tomorrow, Brother Yuan.' Xiao Hua suddenly said to him.

"It's okay, Sect Master. I have someone else who will keep my treasures safe." Yuan said to him.

"If you say so..." Long Yijun nodded with a puzzled look on his face.

Someone else will hold onto his treasures? Who else besides Meixiu will do that?

Sometime later, Long Yijun dismissed them until tomorrow.

Yuan and Meixiu logged off the game to rest for the big event tomorrow.

While dinner was cooking, Meixiu checked the auction, but the price only increased by a few hundred thousand since the last time she checked.

'The auction has slowed down to almost a halt, but it'll pick back up on the final day,' she thought to herself.

After feeding Yuan dinner, Meixiu went to sleep. Yuan also went to sleep since he wanted to rest properly before the big day tomorrow.

Early in the morning tomorrow, way before sunrise, Meixiu woke up and prepared breakfast. After feeding Yuan, they both entered the game.

"Are you all ready?" Long Yijun looked at them.

"Yes, Sect Master!" They all nodded.

"Disciple Yuan, here." Elder Xuan handed Yuan a black mask, but it was made of ordinary material.

"Thank you, Senior Xuan!" Yuan quickly switched from his Black Jade Mask to this black mask made of some kind of marble, giving it a glossy appearance.

Sometime later, the Dragon Essence Temple made their way to the gathering area and stood in a formation like they did yesterday, and they proceeded to wait for Senior Nie to return.

Right before sunrise, Senior Nie returned to the scene and hovered above everyone there.

"Greetings, Senior Nie!"

All of the Sect Masters there bowed to him.

"I will give all of you thirty minutes to prepare before we officially begin the Mystic Realm. If you're prepared, you may stand over there." Senior Nie pointed to the empty area in front of the Mystic Realm.

Soon, participants began gathering at that spot.

"Are you ready, Disciple Yuan?" Long Yijun asked him after asking Xue Jiye and Gao Dongya.

"Give me a second," Yuan said.

Then he said, "Xiao Hua, Feng Feng, you can come outside now."

"Xiao Hua? Feng Feng?" Everyone there raised their eyebrows at these unfamiliar names.

Suddenly, the necklace on Yuan began to glow, and a small ball of flame came out of his chest.

A second later, a cute little girl and a beautiful lady appeared before Yuan like ghosts.

The moment Xiao Hua's presence appeared and Senior Nie sensed it, his eyes widened with immense shock.

"Spirit King?! Impossible!"

Without any hesitation, he immediately flew towards the Dragon Essence Temple.

Chapter 305 - Two Incredibly Powerful Individuals

The other people there immediately noticed Senior Nie's sudden movements and watched as he approached the Dragon Essence Temple.

"S-Senior Nie?!" Long Yijun and the others were shocked by his sudden appearance, and they hastily went to bow to him.

However, almost as though he couldn't see them, Senior Nie ignored them and stared at Xiao Hua with wide eyes filled with surprise. How could such a young girl emit the aura of a Spirit King?

He then clasped his hands and bowed to Xiao Hua in a courteous manner, "What is someone like you doing here, Fellow Daoist? And if you don't mind me asking, where are you from?"

The entire place was dead silent as everyone there watched Senior Nie lower his head and treat a little girl as though they were equals, shocking them greatly.

Nobody there could comprehend the situation. Why was Senior Nie, an envoy from the Spirit Heavens, acting so respectful towards this little girl? However, even more shocking was the way Senior Nie addressed this little girl— Fellow Daoist, which implied that they were on equal footing to a certain extent.

"Xiao Hua's reason for being here doesn't concern you." Xiao Hua said to him in a calm voice that shook the heart of everyone there when they heard it.

How could she treat Senior Nie with such a lack of respect?! Courting death would be an understatement!

A rigid smile appeared on Senior Nie's face after hearing Xiao Hua's disregarding words, but he didn't get angry, even acting like it never happened and said, "Then allow me to ask you another question. How did you, a Spirit King, come down here? Unless one receives permission from the Ji Family, they cannot travel to the Lower Heavens, and as far as I'm aware, I was the only one who'd received permission to come down here in the last 1,000 years."

'A Spirit King?! That little girl?!'

The spectators were shocked to the core after hearing Senior Nie's words. How could a little girl who only appeared to be around 10 years be a Spirit King? Even if she had consumed some sort of appearance-changing pill to alter her appearance, it couldn't possibly change her appearance in such a drastic manner!

However, despite Senior Nie's questioning, Xiao Hua shook her head, seemingly adamant about remaining silent.

"Hmm..." Senior Nie narrowed his eyes at Xiao Hua with a suspicious gaze.

He was only a first level Spirit King whilst Xiao Hua appeared to be at the third level, so there was a good chance he won't be able to defeat her even if they fought. Furthermore, as a Spirit King who came from the upper heavens, Senior Nie has several restrictions placed upon him and cannot cause too much drama in the Lower Heavens or he'll be punished by the heavens.

'This little girl... She doesn't appear to be using any treasures to change her appearance... A Spirit King at such a young age and I don't recognize her... Perhaps she came from a place even higher than Spirit Heavens...?' Senior Nie's body shuddered at the thought that Xiao Hua could be from a place even higher than the Spirit Heavens!

'If that's really the case, I cannot offend her no matter what!' Senior Nie took a deep breath before speaking again, "I apologize if my curiosity has bothered you, Fellow Daoist. If you do not want to say anything, I won't pursue it any further."

Just as Senior Nie prepared to leave, his gaze subconsciously looked at Yuan, who was standing directly next to Xiao Hua.

'A Spirit Master? Wait... I can sense the token on him! Does this mean he's participating in the Mystic Realm—that he's under the age of thirty?'

Senior Nie was greatly surprised to find such tremendous talent in the Lower Heavens, and his anticipation for the Mystic Realm increased significantly.

Although Senior Nie wanted to stay there a little longer to speak with Yuan, he didn't dare to linger too much because of Xiao Hua's presence!

After Senior Nie left the place and returned to his original spot in the air, Long Yijun spoke in a dazed voice, "D-D-Disciple Yuan... T-They are..."

Yuan then said, "Sorry for the late introduction, but they are Xiao Hua and Feng Yuxiang. They're both precious friends who are traveling with me, and they also give me guidance on certain things."

'Xiao Hua? Her voice sounded so familiar... Was she the one who...' Elder Shan subconsciously covered her head when she recalled Xiao Hua's voice who warned her to stay away from Yuan.

"W-Wait a moment... Feng Yuxiang? Golden Phoenix Bazaar's Madam Feng?" Elder Xuan recognized Feng Yuxiang's name because of her widespread fame.

Everybody there was speechless. Why are there two god-like presences so close to Yuan? Had they been following and guarding him this entire time? And just what is Yuan's true background? Not even people from the Four Ancient Families would have a Spirit King and a peak Spirit Grandmaster as bodyguards!

Meanwhile, at the Heaven and Earth Palace's group, their Sect Master, Qi Jiguang, looked at Xiao Hua with wide eyes.

'That little girl! I remember seeing her at the Azure Phoenix Auction House! She was a Spirit King this entire time!?' He easily recalled Xiao Hua mostly because of her distinctive small figure and powerful aura.

No matter how much they tried, the people there could not take their eyes off Xiao Hua and Feng Yuxiang because of their immense presence that overshadowed even Senior Nie's presence!

In their eyes, Xiao Hua was a mysterious expert whom Senior Nie acknowledges as a fellow Spirit King Cultivator! And although it took some time, the people there eventually recognized Feng Yuxiang and her beauty as the number one expert of Phoenix City and also the owner of one of the most prestigious shops in the Lower Heavens!

Why on earth were these two incredibly powerful individuals in this place? And why are they standing with the Dragon Essence Temple? It was incomprehensible for everybody there except the person who brought them to this place— Yuan!

Chapter 306 - Shattering Their Confidence

Many minutes have passed since the conversation between Senior Nie and Xiao Hua ended, but the atmosphere there remained heavy, almost suffocating, especially for those people standing closest to the Dragon Essence Temple.

"Xiao Hua, here are my treasures. Please hold onto them while I enter the Mystic Realm." Yuan handed Xiao Hua his spatial ring and storage pouch.

"Xiao Hua will protect the treasures without fail!" Xiao Hua said to him with a serious look on her face, acting like she was handed a big responsibility.

"Who would dare to steal from a Spirit King in the Lower Heavens?" Feng Yuxiang raised her eyebrows.

Xiao Hua could leave Yuan's treasure on the ground, go take a nap, and come back with the treasure still on the ground, completely untouched.

"By the way, what are you going to do with your Soul Weapons, Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang suddenly asked him.

"S-Soul Weapon?!" Long Yijun and the others turned to look at them with wide eyes filled with shock after hearing their conversation, even ignoring how Feng Yuxiang addressed Yuan as 'Young Master'.

"Huh? What do you mean? I can't take treasures inside so I'll have to leave it out here obviously." Yuan said.

"But Soul Weapons are unique... They must be within a certain distance from its Master— there's no way around it."

"Eh? What happens if I am too far away from them?" Yuan then asked.

"I think it would be better if I showed it to you..." Feng Yuxiang said, and she continued, "Can you hand me one of your Soul Weapons for a moment?"

Yuan nodded, and he retrieved the Starry Abyss from the spatial ring before handing it to Feng Yuxiang.

Once she had the Starry Abyss in her grasp, Feng Yuxiang suddenly took off into the sky and flew away, acting like a thief during a grab-and-run situation.

Feng Yuxiang's sudden movements attracted the attention of everybody there, including Senior Nie.

'Where's she going?' They all wondered.

However, Senior Nie was more interested in the Starry Abyss that was within her grasp.

"Is that... a Soul Weapon?" Senior Nie mumbled in a dumbfounded voice, as he didn't expect to find a Soul Weapon in the Lower Heavens.

In just a few minutes, Feng Yuxiang managed to fly almost a hundred miles away from the Mystic Realm, and right as she reached the 100th-mile mark, the Starry Abyss in her hand suddenly disappeared.

Meanwhile, at the Mystic Realm, Yuan was surprised when the Starry Abyss suddenly appeared before him like a ghost.

"How did..." Yuan was completely baffled by this phenomenon.

"Soul Weapons are bound to their owners. If they get too far away from their masters, they will immediately teleport back to them, almost as if they have a mind of their own." Xiao Hua explained to him.

Feng Yuxiang returned sometime later.

"Do you understand now, Young Master? You won't be able to escape your Soul Weapons. However, I don't know how it'll work with the Mystic Realm." Feng Yuxiang said to him.

A moment after Feng Yuxiang's words, Senior Nie's voice suddenly resounded, "Soul Weapons are an exception and allowed inside the Mystic Realm since they are considered as 'part of the individual'. I didn't mention it at first because I didn't think there would be someone with a Soul Weapon here. Congratulations, young man— you're now a few hundred steps ahead of everyone else before you're even inside the Mystic Realm."

"What?! He can bring a powerful treasure inside while the rest of us have to go inside empty-handed?! That's so unfair!"

The other participants immediately started complaining, feeling extremely envious of Yuan's Soul Weapon.

"I see... Then I will bring my Soul Weapons with me." Yuan said.

"Huh? Soul Weapons...?" Long Yijun and the others raised their eyebrows.

"Y-You have more than one?" Elder Xuan asked him in a dazed voice.

Yuan nodded, and he proceeded to take out his other Soul Weapon, Empyrean Overlord.

Forget about the others, even Senior Nie's jaw dropped when he saw Yuan holding two Soul Weapons— one in each hand.

Ignoring the difficulty of obtaining two Soul Weapons, what kind of talent is required to wield two Soul Weapons at the same time? Senior Nie has never seen such talents before even within the Spirit Heavens, and they have plenty of heavenly geniuses that would put most of the people here to shame.

'Just who is that young man?! I cannot see the full extent of his talents!' Senior Nie cried inwardly.

"By the way, Young Master, you can store your Soul Weapons within your body." Feng Yuxiang said to him.

"Really? How do I do that?" Yuan asked.

"Just imagine your body as a spatial ring and the Soul Weapons being stored inside your body."

Yuan nodded his head and followed Feng Yuxiang's instructions.

A moment later, the Empyrean Overlord and Starry Abyss disappeared from his hands, yet he could still feel their presence inside his body, almost like how Feng Yuxiang dwells within his body!

"I think I am ready to enter the Mystic Realm! I will see you all later!" Yuan said to Long Yijun and the others who were too dazed to respond properly.

"Y-Yeah... G-Good luck..." Long Yijun mumbled in a low voice.

"See you later, Disciple Yuan..." Elder Shan and Elder Xuan said.

"Don't go easy on them, Disciple Yuan." Elder Dai said to him with a smile on her face.

"That's right! Go beat them senseless, Young Master! Make them regret being born!" Feng Yuxiang cheered for him.

"Have fun, Brother Yuan." Xiao Hua said to him with a relaxed expression, almost like she had no concern at all— that she was absolutely confident in Yuan's ability.

"See you later, Yuan," Meixiu said to him.

After saying his goodbyes, Yuan, Xue Jiye, and Gao Dongya approached the other participants with the token in their grasp.

It was at this moment the Sect Masters and all of the experts there realized something, as they were too shocked by many other things to realize this before.

"W-Wait a damn moment! That Spirit Master was a participant this entire time?! But he's clearly wearing the sect elders' uniform for the Dragon Essence Temple! And if I didn't mention it already— he's a damn Spirit Master!"

"That's right! How could a Spirit Master possibly qualify for the Mystic Realm?! What's going on here, Sect Master Long?!"

The experts there didn't want to believe that someone under 30 years old could possibly become a Spirit Master. If someone like that truly exists and enters the Mystic Realm... The other participants won't be able to compete with someone like that! It'd be a one-sided slaughter!

Long Yijun burst out laughing after seeing the other Sect Masters' reactions, and he spoke in a loud and clear voice so that everybody could hear him—

"I know many of you are in disbelief and doubting everything at this moment, and I do not blame you for that! In fact, I would probably be doing the same thing if I were in your shoes! However, this is reality! Not only is my disciple a Spirit Master, but he's also only eighteen years old! Hahaha! Good luck to everyone participating in the Mystic Realm! If I were to give you one piece of advice— give up while you can!"

The complexion of the Sect Masters and the participants alike turned as white as sheets after hearing Long Yijun's words, their faces filled with disbelief and immense shock.

Reaching Spirit Master as an eighteen-year-old? Where on earth did this cultivation monster come from? And why does the Dragon Essence Temple have someone like him helping them out?

"Spirit Master... Eighteen years old?" Senior Nie mumbled in a low voice, subconsciously comparing Yuan's talents to the top geniuses within the Spirit Heavens.

Meanwhile, the other participants stared at Yuan with gawking looks on their faces as they watched him slowly approach them with an

unfathomable aura surrounding his figure at this moment.

In their eyes, Yuan looked much bigger than he did a moment ago, almost like he'd suddenly grown a couple of meters, and they felt like ants in comparison to his awe-inspiring presence.

And when they realized that they were going to compete against this cultivation monster in the Mystic Realm, their confidence shattered like glass under the force of a hammer.

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Chapter 307 - Entering The Mystic Realm

'Impossible! This is impossible! There's no way we can beat a monster like him! He's way above our league!'

The participants felt as though someone from the upper heavens suddenly decided to come down to the Lower Heavens just to mess with them by showing off his heaven-defying talents in the Mystic Realm where only talents mattered.

Even for the sects with more than three tokens, they didn't feel any confidence in defeating the Dragon Essence Temple that only has three slots. In fact, even if the Dragon Essence Temple only had one slot and Yuan occupied that slot, they still wouldn't have any confidence despite having the advantage in numbers.

'Two Soul Weapons and a Spirit Master cultivation base... The Mystic Realm is going to be exciting this year...' Senior Nie smiled inwardly as his gaze remained on Yuan's figure.

Once the Dragon Essence Temple joined the other participants, Senior Nie spoke loudly, "I will open the Mystic Realm in five minutes! Use this time to prepare yourself if you haven't already!"

The next five minutes felt like an eternity for the participants and the Sect Masters alike. Even though it was a rare opportunity for these participants to show off their talents before someone from the Spirit Heavens, this cultivation monster came out of the blue and stole all of the spotlights without any effort.

Meanwhile, the players were more shocked about Yuan's age, as that gave them a little more information on his mysterious identity.

'Player Yuan is only eighteen years old? What a discovery! He's around my age!' Wang Xiuying thought to herself, feeling pleasantly surprised.

'Spirit Master... He definitely has the highest cultivation base out of all players as of this moment!' Lightning Emperor thought to himself, realizing just how much he'd underestimated Player Yuan's advantage.

Five minutes of absolute silence later, Senior Nie spoke, "I forgot to mention one more thing— once you go inside, every sect will be separated from each other so you won't immediately start fighting with each other the moment you go inside."

After his sentence ended, Senior Nie began making weird signs with his hands before shouting out loud, "OPEN!"

The symbols on each side of the gates suddenly began glowing golden, and the light coming from the Mystic Realm gradually grew brighter and brighter until it was nearly blinding.

All of the participants narrowed their eyes at this bright light, and unbeknownst to them, they were fully enveloped by this warm light.

Once the light subdued, the Sect Masters turned to look at the place where the participants had gathered, and as they'd expected, it was completely empty there, almost like all of the participants had disappeared like a ghost.

"They have successfully entered the Mystic Realm." Senior Nie said to them before waving his hands and retrieving this massive mirror from his spatial ring, putting it directly in front of the Sect Masters.

"We will be able to see the participants inside the Mystic Realm with this Mirror of Surveillance." Senior Nie said.

A few moments later, the Sect Masters could see their own disciples in the mirror as well as the other participants, almost like they were watching a

movie or something.

However, Senior Nie was not finished, and he brought out a couple of crystal balls— seven to be exact— that hovered in the air around him.

"Connect!" Senior Nie suddenly said.

The seven crystal balls began glowing a subtle blue light.

"Can you all see it?" Senior Nie asked the crystal balls as though he was speaking to them.

"Yes... I can see it perfectly. Thank you for your troubles, Elder Nie." A feminine voice resounded from one of the seven crystals.

"It finally started, huh? I wonder if there are any promising talents this year. What do you think, Senior Nie?" Another voice resounded from a new crystal.

"There are definitely a few," Senior Nie nodded.

"Hoh... My anticipation just went up."

Senior Nie then looked at the Sect Masters and the other spectators and said, "They are all sect elders from each of the seven Spirit Academies, and they will be watching the spectacle with us."

"Greetings, Seniors!"

The Sect Masters there greeted the experts behind the crystal balls.

"Good luck to all of your disciples!" One of the crystals responded, sounding rather friendly.

Meanwhile, once their vision returned, the participants were surprised to find themselves transported to some unfamiliar land.

"So this is the Mystic Realm?" Xue Jiye looked at her surroundings with a slightly dazed look on her face, realizing that they were no longer at the

Desolate Land but in a grassland in the middle of nowhere.

"Hey." Gao Dongya suddenly spoke.

"Hm? What is it?" Xue Jiye turned to look at his handsome face that had a frown on it.

"Where's our third person?" Gao Dongya said in a serious voice.

"Eh?" Xue Jiye's eyes widened with surprise after hearing his words, and she immediately looked around them. However, she could only see Gao Dongya there with her.

"Where's Disciple Yuan?! I thought he was supposed to be with us! Why did he get separated from us?!" Xue Jiye exclaimed.

"Disciple Yuan! Are you here?!" Xue Jiye began shouting his name at the top of her lungs, hoping that he was actually near them.

But alas, nobody responded to her.

"Disciple Yuan!" Xue Jiye did not want to believe that they had been separated and continued shouting his name.

"Stop your shouting, woman! It's clear that he was separated from us after entering the Mystic Realm! What are you going to do if you attract unwanted attention with your loudmouth? We don't have any cultivation to protect ourselves at this moment!" Gao Dongya said to her.

"W-Woman? Loudmouth?" Xue Jiye stared at Gao Dongya with a surprised look, as this is her first time seeing him being so vocal.

"Anyways, we can only focus on ourselves for now and look for him later when we have some capability to protect ourselves. Let's find someplace where we can cultivate." Gao Dongya then said.

Although she was not happy about the way Gao Dongya addressed her, Xue Jiye couldn't find any fault in his logic and nodded her head in agreement.

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Chapter 308 - Separated From The Team

While Xue Jiye and Gao Dongya looked around for a secure spot where they could cultivate safely, outside the Mystic Realm, Long Yijun and the others were baffled by Yuan's disappearance.

"W-Where's Disciple Yuan? I thought each sect was supposed to be transported together?" Elder Shan mumbled in a dazed voice.

The other Sect Masters were also puzzled by this since they were also looking for Yuan, who was the number one threat to them at this moment.

"Where's the Young Master? I can't see him in the mirror at all!" Feng Yuxiang exclaimed after looking at every sect in the mirror.

Meanwhile, on Xiao Hua's face was a deep frown, looking quite worried, even a little bit angry.

BOOM!

Suddenly, Xiao Hua released her third level Spirit King cultivation base, scaring the living hell out of everybody there.

Then they watched as Xiao Hua retrieved a massive sword that was thrice her size before flying towards Senior Nie, looking very aggressive.

Senior Nie nearly had a heart attack when he saw Xiao Hua flying at him with a huge sword, and he also retrieved his own weapon to defend himself.

"What do you think you're doing, Fellow Daoist?! Are you trying to anger the heavens by causing a commotion in the Lower Heavens?!" Senior Nie

asked her.

"What happened?"

"Who's the little girl?"

The voices coming from the crystal ball were filled with shock and puzzlement when they saw a little girl attack Senior Nie.

Xiao Hua stopped a few meters away from Senior Nie before pointing her massive sword at him and speaking in a serious voice, "What did you do to Brother Yuan?! If you lie, I will cut you down!"

"Yuan... Are you talking about that talented young man with the black mask? I had nothing to do with his disappearance, and I am as puzzled as you are! Furthermore, I only have the power to open and close the Mystic Realm, nothing else! Once they enter the Mystic Realm, I have no control!" Senior Nie said.

"Calm down and put your sword away before you anger the heavens!" Senior Nie then said.

"..."

Xiao Hua did not immediately put her sword away and stared at Senior Nie in silence.

A few moments later, Xiao Hua lowered the sword, handling the massive thing as though it was as light as a branch.

Senior Nie glanced at the sword in Xiao Hua's hands, and his heart skipped a beat when he realized its quality.

'Mythic-grade treasure?!' he cried inwardly.

Mythic-grade treasures were two grades above Divine-grade, and they are almost nonexistent even in the Spirit Heavens!

'This little girl is definitely from a place even higher than Spirit Heavens! I cannot offend her no matter what!'

Senior Nie cleared his throat before speaking, "I know you're worried about that young man's disappearance, but believe me when I say you don't have to. The Mystic Realm is not an evil place. In fact, it's the complete opposite, being a place where people can go inside and train, and nobody has ever died inside."

"As for why that young man was separated from his group, one can only assume that the Mystic Realm made a mistake and separated him by accident. But you don't have to worry since he'll most likely show up sooner or later."

After a moment of silence, Xiao Hua said, "If Brother Yuan doesn't return in one month, Xiao Hua will make you take responsibility."

Senior Nie swallowed nervously after hearing Xiao Hua's threatening words.

"Hey! Who do you think you're talking to?! That's Senior Nie from—"

"I understand." Senior Nie interrupted one of the voices coming from the crystal ball, and he continued, "I will take full responsibility if that young man doesn't return."

Xiao Hua nodded her head before returning to the Dragon Essence Temple's side and proceeded to act as nothing had happened, dumbfounding everyone there.

"Who was that little girl just now?" One of the voices from the crystal ball asked afterward.

"I don't know. However, she's a third-level Spirit King with a Mythic-grade treasure... I'm pretty confident that she came from a realm even above the Spirit Heavens." Senior Nie explained to them.

"What?! Above the Spirit Heavens?! What is such an individual doing at the Lower Heavens?!"

The voices expressed their shock and disbelief.

"I know. I almost couldn't believe it at first, but I don't know of a 'Xiao Hua' in the Spirit Heavens, and there's no way such an individual could be a nobody." Senior Nie sighed, and he continued, "As for that young man, I can only hope that he returns, or my life is in danger..."

The crystal balls remained silent. None of them would have imagined that such a situation could be possible—that a Spirit King's life could be in danger in the Lower Heavens where Spirit Lords are nonexistent, much less a Spirit King!

"You worry too much, Xiao Hua. The Young Master will be fine even if the heavens fall on him." Feng Yuxiang said to her after she returned.

Xiao Hua didn't say anything, only nodding her head, still with a slight frown on her face.

Meanwhile, inside the Mystic Realm, after opening his eyes, Yuan found himself surrounded by dried trees and leaves.

"Where am I? What happened to the other two?" Yuan raised his eyebrows with a puzzled look on his face.

"Disciple Xue? Disciple Gao? Are you two here?" Yuan shouted their names, but alas, there was no response, almost like he was the only one there.

After standing around for a few moments, Yuan suddenly turned to look in a certain direction, as he could hear a faint whisper coming from that direction.

"Come..."

"Here..."

"Who's there?!" Yuan called out to the voice.

However, the voice continued to beckon him.

"Come..."

"Come..."

"Here..."

Yuan swallowed nervously. Although the voice gave an eerie vibe, he couldn't feel any malice from it.

After pondering for a moment, Yuan decided to follow this voice.

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Chapter 309 - Following The Voice

"Here..."

"Come... Here..."

The voice continued to beckon Yuan, its volume increasing the longer he followed the voice.

While Yuan subconsciously followed the voice, he checked his own body.

Cultivation: First Level Spirit Apprentice

Legacy: None

Bloodline: None

Physique: Heaven Refining Physique

Physical Strength: 134

Mental Strength: 375

Soul Strength: 1,310

Physical Defense: 110

Mental Defense: 1,221

His cultivation had been wiped like they said it would, and he was only at the first level Spirit Apprentice. However, for whatever reason, he didn't feel as weak as he did when he was at the same level before. Perhaps it was

the Soul Weapons in his body, but he felt pretty confident in his own strength despite his low cultivation base.

As for his techniques, all of them remained unchanged. However, if he wanted to use them, he'd need to increase his Qi because he wouldn't be able to use most of his techniques at his current cultivation base.

Half an hour later, Yuan suddenly stopped walking when he realized that the voice was no longer calling for him.

He looked around, and to his surprise, he could see an ancient-looking temple in the distance from where he was standing.

"Is this the place the voice wanted me to go to?" Yuan mumbled to himself as he approached this temple that was about half a mile away.

As Yuan got closer to the temple, he realized how run down the place looked, almost like it had existed for tens of thousands of years.

Yuan stood directly in front of the staircase that led to the temple a few minutes later with a pondering expression on his face.

'Does that voice belong to the faceless person? Why is it calling for me?' he wondered.

After standing there for a few moments, Yuan decided to walk up the stairs and enter the temple since he won't have any answers without approaching the source.

There were exactly 100 steps on the staircase to the temple, and upon reaching the top, Yuan could see the inside of this temple through the empty doorway.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan entered the temple.

Inside the temple was a long and empty room except for the 10-meter tall stone tablet at the end of this room that had refined angles and clean words engraved onto it, looking pristine overall, almost like it was newly built, in

contrast to the rest of the temple that was ancient and on the verge of collapsing.

Furthermore, there was not even a speck of dust on this tablet made of marble, almost as though someone cleaned it very recently.

Yuan tilted his head to look at the words carved into this tablet, but alas, he was unable to understand the language. However, despite not understanding a thing, Yuan still felt a sense of awe and dominance from the way the words were carved into the stone tablet, as each line was filled with precision and confidence.

"What's this feeling I'm getting from these words? It feels so familiar for some reason..." Yuan gently caressed the words on the stone tablet with his fingers, feeling slightly nostalgic, almost like he'd seen these words before.

"Anyways, what happened to the voice?"

Yuan then looked around while speaking in a loud voice, "Why did it call me to this place? I am here just like you wanted! Say something! Anything!"

"..."

However, there was no response.

Yuan scratched his head, unsure of what he should do now.

"Well, I should follow the Sect Master's instructions and quickly increase my cultivation base before I roam the Mystic Realm."

Before entering the Mystic Realm, Long Yijun gave them some advice, and one of them was to start cultivating as soon as they can so they have some capabilities to protect themselves.

Yuan proceeded to sit down directly in front of the stone tablet and took a deep breath before he began cultivating.

[Due to your title Pang City's Hero, cultivation speed has increased by 10%]

[Due to your Untainted Body, cultivation speed has increased by 100%]

[Due to the Nine Dragon Symbols, your cultivation speed has increased by 1,000%]

[Environmental effect has increased your cultivation speed by 400%]

"What? 400 percent? This place is almost like the Dragon Peak that had 500 percent!"

Yuan was shocked by this large number. Is this because of the immense spiritual energy in the Mystic Realm or this place specifically?

He recalls Long Yijun mentioning about the Mystic Realm having an abundant amount of spiritual energy, but he didn't expect it to be this much. At this rate, he'll reach Spirit Warrior in no time!

Thus, Yuan began reciting the cultivation technique in his head, absorbing the spiritual energy in the temple at a rapid pace.

[+7,502 Qi]

[+7,411 Qi]

[You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough]

[You have reached Second Level Spirit Apprentice]

[All stats +150]

After literally two seconds of cultivation, Yuan had a breakthrough and reached the second level.

A few more seconds later, he enters the third level and so on.

[You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough]

[You have reached Third Level Spirit Apprentice]

[You have reached Fourth Level Spirit Apprentice]

[You have reached Fifth Level Spirit Apprentice]

[You have reached Sixth Level Spirit Apprentice]

In slightly less than 10 minutes since he started cultivating, Yuan had managed to increase his cultivation base by an entire realm, entering first level Spirit Warrior with ease.

[You have reached First Level Spirit Warrior]

[All stats +1,000]

Yuan stood up to stretch after entering the Spirit Warrior realm for the third time in this life.

"The voice still hasn't returned. Why exactly did it bring me to this place? It probably has something to do with this stone tablet but I don't understand it." Yuan sighed.

Just as he prepared to sit back down and cultivate some more, Yuan heard a gentle voice resound behind him, causing him to turn around.

"Umm... Who are you?" This voice asked him in a slightly nervous tone.

When Yuan turned around, he could see a pretty young lady with silky long black hair and azure blue eyes wearing plain green clothes standing at the entrance of the temple, and on her face was a slightly surprised expression, almost like she didn't expect to see anyone in this place. Furthermore, she was holding a bamboo basket in her arms, looking like she was a villager out to gather herbs.

However, what surprised him the most was the powerful aura that surrounded this young lady's figure.

'A Spirit Master!' Yuan cried inwardly.

He had mistaken this young lady as a fellow participant at first, but there is no way anyone would be able to reach Spirit Master so quickly when their cultivation bases were wiped after entering this place, so there was only one explanation for this— this young lady was a native in the Mystic Realm!

To think he'd encounter a Spirit Master Cultivator so quickly after entering the Mystic Realm, nobody would've ever imagined this. However, whether this encounter is a fortunate one or not is still unknown.

"Hello..." Yuan greeted her in a friendly voice, and he continued, "My name is Yuan."

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Chapter 310 - Sword Marks

"Yuan...?" The azure-eyed beauty raised her eyebrows, and she asked, "I don't recognize you. What are you doing here at my Lord's stone tablet?"

"Your lord...? I'll apologize in advance if I am not supposed to be here, but I was called here by a voice." Yuan said to her.

"A voice? What did the voice tell you?" The azure-eyed beauty asked him, seemingly intrigued by his situation.

"It only told me to come here," Yuan shrugged.

"Is that so..." The azure-eyed beauty mumbled before she started moving again, approaching his direction— or more specifically, the stone tablet behind Yuan.

"I'll assume that you're not from around here since I don't recognize your aura," she said to him.

"Yes... I came here with my fellow disciples, but we somehow got separated." Yuan explained his situation briefly.

"I see..."

The azure-eyed lady stopped moving once she stood directly in front of the stone tablet.

She then placed the bamboo basket in her arms down before kneeling on the floor and kowtowing to the stone tablet.

After a moment of stillness, the young lady lifted her head and retrieved a towel from the basket, and she began wiping the stone tablet as though it

was a fragile treasure.

"Umm... What is this place?" Yuan decided to ask her.

"This place doesn't have a name, nor does it have any other purpose besides housing my Lord's stone tablet," she responded in a calm voice.

"Your Lord?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"Yes, my family served him for countless generations, and it's my job to clean his stone tablet once a month. However, I come here at least once a week since I have nothing else to do."

After spending a few minutes cleaning the stone tablet, she turned to look at Yuan in the eyes and spoke, "You mentioned a voice calling you to this place, right?"

Yuan nodded his head.

"Well... There's actually a barrier made of Sword Aura protecting this temple if you didn't know, and unless you're protected by my family's blessing, it's impossible to get near this place, much less enter the temple..." The azure-eyed lady revealed to him.

"Sword Aura?" Yuan mumbled in a low voice, finding this word very familiar.

After pondering for a moment, he recalled Xiao Hua briefly explaining Sword Aura to him before.

"I don't know how you bypassed the barrier, nor anything about this voice you heard, but you're here for a reason."

"I see... thank you... uhh... Can I get your name?" Yuan asked her upon realizing that she hasn't introduced herself yet.

The young lady then spoke, "My name is Lan Yingying, and I'm the guardian of this unnamed temple."

"Ummm, Miss Lan, if you don't mind me asking, do you know what's written on this stone tablet? Maybe it'll give me a hint or something." Yuan suddenly asked her.

Lan Yingying turned to look at the stone tablet and said, "The words written on my Lord's stone tablet don't mean anything— if you can even call it that."

"Huh? What do you mean?"

"These symbols are sword marks created by my Lord when he was still alive and practicing his Sword Aura. At least that's what the legend says." Lan Yingying said.

"Legend? How long has it been since he passed away?"

Lan Yingying shook her head and said, "We don't know for sure when he disappeared, but it was definitely a few hundred thousand years ago."

"A-A few hundred thousand years ago?!?!" Yuan exclaimed, as he truly didn't expect that this person had been dead for such a long time.

"And you're still cleaning his stone tablet despite such a long time? What's the purpose?" Yuan couldn't help but ask.

"When my Lord was still alive, he accepted my family's ancestors as his servants, and our family has been serving him since then— even if he's no longer in this world. Cleaning his stone tablet has become a tradition in my family since his disappearance." Lan Yingying said.

"Anyways, I will be leaving now. I don't mind if you stay here, but don't make a mess, or I'll get angry." Lan Yingying said to him before leaving the temple.

"..."

Yuan decided to remain in this place since he wanted to be sure that there's really nothing here for him.

After Lan Yingying left the place, Yuan took a seat in front of the stone tablet again. Although he wasn't sure what was so special about the stone tablet, he had a feeling that it was related to why he was called here.

Thus, he began cultivating again.

About an hour and a half later, he entered second-level Spirit Warrior.

Another hour later, he breakthroughs to third level Spirit Warrior.

Yuan took a deep breath and opened his eyes, stopping his cultivation to look at the stone tablet in front of him.

"Sword marks..." Yuan's gaze focused on the incredibly clean and sharp marks on the tablet.

After spending two hours looking at the sword marks, Yuan returned to cultivating for another two hours, reaching the fourth level Spirit Warrior realm.

Yuan repeated this process until the sky began turning dark.

At the end of the day, he'd managed to reach the fifth level Spirit Warrior realm.

After logging off the game, Yuan could already smell Meixiu cooking dinner.

"What happened to you, Yuan? You weren't with the other two disciples." Meixiu asked him during dinner.

"I don't know, either. I was separated from them before I was aware of it."

"Are you okay?"

"Yes, I found this pretty safe area and managed to increase my cultivation base to the fifth level Spirit Warrior realm."

"Xiao Hua... she was really worried about you. She even..." Meixiu said, and she explained the situation that had occurred after his disappearance.

"What? Xiao Hua did that? Can you tell her not to worry and that I am okay after dinner?" Yuan quickly said.

"I will." Meixiu nodded.

"Thank you."

After dinner, Yuan returned to Cultivation Online to cultivate some more whilst Meixiu went to deliver the news of Yuan's situation to Xiao Hua and the others.

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Chapter 311 - Studying Sword Aura

"Welcome back, Meixiu." Feng Yuxiang said to her the moment she logged back inside, acting as though her disappearance was only natural.

Meixiu nodded and said, "I have some news for you regarding Yuan."

"Brother Yuan?" Xiao Hua was the one to react upon hearing his name, and she quickly asked, "What about Brother Yuan?!"

"I just wanted to let you know that even though he's separated from the other two disciples, he's still safe and sound," Meixiu said.

"What? How do you know that? Did you contact him somehow?" Long Yijun looked at her with a face of disbelief. How could one contact someone that's inside the Mystic Realm? He has never heard of this before.

Meixiu nodded, "Yes, I have a method of contacting Yuan."

"So Brother Yuan is safe?" Xiao Hua asked her again just in case.

"Yes, he's safe and well. In fact, he's even reached fifth level Spirit Warrior."

"What?! Fifth level Spirit Warrior?! But he's only been inside for a day!" Elder Shan exclaimed in a shocked voice.

"Heavens... At this rate, he'll return to his original cultivation base in no time..." Elder Xuan mumbled.

"Hahaha! As expected of Disciple Yuan! His talents know no bounds!" Long Yijun laughed out loud.

The other sects looked at the Dragon Essence Temple as though they were crazy. What the heck are they talking about? Their number one disciple is missing and they look quite happy, and the Sect Master is even laughing out loud.

"Thank heavens..." Xiao Hua released a sigh of relief after hearing that Yuan was fine.

Meanwhile, inside the Mystic Realm, Yuan spends another hour looking at the stone tablet.

"Miss Lan mentioned that this place is surrounded by Sword Aura. Now that I'm a Spirit Warrior again, I can use my Divine Sense. Let's see if I can see this Sword Aura with my Divine Sense..."

Thus, Yuan closed his eyes and activated his Divine Sense, extending it as far as he could manage.

But alas, he was unable to 'see' this Sword Aura. However, with that being said, he could sense an unfamiliar aura around the temple.

"Is this Sword Aura? I can sense it but not see it..." Yuan mumbled in a pondering voice.

He continued to 'feel' this Sword Aura, trying to understand it for as long as his Divine Sense could hold up.

When he could no longer use his Divine Sense due to exhaustion, he began cultivating to restore his spiritual energy.

Once he was full of energy again, Yuan used his Divine Sense to inspect the Sword Aura around the place, and the longer he looked at it, the more he understood it— at least that was the feeling he was getting.

It was almost like that time when Xiao Hua read her book to him for the first time. He couldn't comprehend a single thing at first, but as he listened

to it, he gradually understood it more and more until he eventually learned the technique.

Thus, from night to sunrise, Yuan studied the Sword Aura in fascination, almost like he was mesmerized by its existence.

Yuan logged off for breakfast, returning shortly after to study it some more.

In the afternoon, Yuan retrieved his Divine Sense and took a deep breath afterward.

He then turned to look at the sword marks on the stone tablet, and he proceeded to stare at it for hours without moving a single muscle.

Suddenly, he began closing his eyes, feeling a familiar sensation overwhelm his body.

"This feeling... Enlightenment?" Yuan mumbled in a low voice as his mind drifted.

Even though his eyes were closed, Yuan could still see the stone tablet in his mind, and he could see each and every sword mark clearly, almost like he still had his eyes open.

Suddenly, the sword marks on the stone tablet began disappearing.

A few moments later, all of the sword marks disappeared with the stone tablet completely clean and untouched.

A few more seconds later, Yuan could see a figure suddenly appear before the stone tablet with its back facing him, and in this figure's grasp was an ordinary sword.

Yuan then watched as this figure raised the sword in its grasp and struck the stone tablet repeatedly, creating multiple sword marks on it.

A few minutes later, the stone tablet returned to its original form with many sword marks on it.

However, the sword marks disappeared again a few seconds later.

Once all of the sword marks were gone, the figure repeated the actions and struck the stone tablet with its sword using the exact same movements, and this scene repeated tens— hundreds of times inside Yuan's head.

Yuan's enlightenment continued throughout the night, even forgetting to log off for dinner.

"He's still inside the game?" After cooking dinner, Meixiu waited for Yuan to come out of the game, but in the end, he remained inside the game.

And not wanting to disturb him, Meixiu quietly put his dinner in the refrigerator before calling it a night.

The following morning, Meixiu woke up to see Yuan's condition, but alas, he was still inside the game.

Meixiu decided to not log into the game until Yuan returns like last time. While she waited, she went to look at the auction and other things online to kill time.

Meanwhile, inside Cultivation Online, Yuan had just witnessed the figure strike the stone tablet thousands of times. And with every strike, he could sense the Sword Aura from the sword and the sword marks much clearer.

Suddenly, Yuan stood up inside his mind, and he approached the figure.

A few seconds later, Yuan stood exactly where the figure once stood and with a sword in his grasp.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan began replicating the figure's sword movement, almost like he'd become that figure himself.

One... two... three...

Yuan struck the stone tablet three times, but there were no marks on the stone tablet.

However, Yuan didn't stop and continued to strike the stone tablet.

One hundred... two hundred... three hundred strikes.

After striking the stone tablet hundreds of times inside his mind, completely unbeknownst to him, a profound aura that resembled Sword Aura began appearing around Yuan's real body!

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Chapter 312 - Advanced Sword Mastery

"I wonder if that young man is still there..." Lan Yingying mumbled to herself as she approached the unnamed temple shortly after sunrise.

While she normally visits the temple once a week to clean the stone tablet, she has been experiencing a weird sensation in her chest ever since she met the masked man two days ago, almost like her guts was telling her to return to the temple.

About half an hour of walking later, Lan Yingying arrived at the temple, and she could already feel something different in the air before she even stepped onto the staircase to the temple.

"This aura... It can't be..." Lan Yingying quickly ascended the staircase when she realized the type of aura she was experiencing.

A few moments later, she stood at the entrance of the temple and looked inside, and to her surprise, the masked person was still there. Furthermore, there was even a subtle amount of Sword Aura emitting from his body!

Of course, the most shocking part about all of this was his cultivation base which had increased exponentially since their last meeting only two days ago!

'My lord! He was a first level Spirit Warrior just two days ago! Now, he's a fifth level Spirit Warrior?! How can anyone cultivate so fast?!' Lan Yingying covered her mouth in shock when she realized Yuan's immense growth.

She has seen many geniuses in her lifetime, but she has never seen someone with as much talent as this masked individual, who'd managed to learn Sword Aura as a Spirit Warrior.

No... There is one person she can think of who could possibly rival this person in terms of talent—the 'Lord' her family used to serve who was known to have unrivaled talents and a legendary swordmaster.

Lan Yingying didn't want to disturb Yuan, so she quietly turned around and prepared to leave.

However, just as she turned around, she noticed a change on the stone tablet that she has cleaned ever since she could walk.

'T-The sword marks! They're reacting to that individual's Sword Aura?! Impossible!' Lan Yingying nearly cried out loud after seeing the Sword Aura that was left behind by the person who made the sword marks reacting for the first time in her life.

'W-Who is this person?!' Lan Yingying wondered with a serious look on her face, and she decided to stay around to witness the situation for a little bit longer.

Meanwhile, inside Yuan's head, he struck the stone tablet for the thousandth time, creating a small cut on the stone tablet, and the sword in his grasp was emitting weak Sword Aura.

'This... This is the feeling I was looking for!'

Yuan's eyes flickered with profoundness, and he continued to strike the stone tablet.

The more he practiced his Sword Aura, the deeper and cleaner the cuts got.

Two thousand... five thousand... ten thousand...

Yuan struck the stone tablet over ten thousand times without stopping, his understanding of Sword Aura increasing with every strike.

Meanwhile, the training inside his mind also reflected in the real world, as his Sword Aura grew increasingly stronger and sharper. If one were to drop a piece of paper on top of Yuan right now, it would definitely be torn to shred the moment it touches the Sword Aura surrounding him.

Lan Yingying watched as Yuan improved his Sword Aura at a frightening rate.

Suddenly, she noticed that the Sword Aura in the sword marks was actually leaving the stone tablet and being absorbed by Yuan's Sword Aura!

'What?! He's absorbing my Lord's Sword Aura?! No— My Lord's Sword Aura is attracted to him! It's going towards him on its own will!' Lan Yingying was shocked to the core when she realized what was happening.

It took a couple of hours, but eventually, Yuan absorbed all of the Sword Aura on the stone tablet.

WHOOSH!

A powerful gust of wind swept the place when Yuan absorbed the last bit of Sword Aura from the stone tablet.

Lan Yingying, who was standing all the way at the entrance, noticed small tears on her clothes when the Sword Aura touched her despite standing so far away from Yuan.

'What intense Sword Aura!' Lan Yingying didn't care about her clothes being destroyed by Yuan's Sword Aura— or more precisely, she was too focused on him to care about such a minor thing.

The Sword Aura around Yuan subdued a few moments later, and he opened his eyes, taking a deep breath afterward.

[Your mastery with the sword has improved significantly]

[Your understanding of swords has reached a new level]

[Your 'Novice Sword Mastery' has developed into 'Advanced Sword Mastery']

[You have understood the basics of Sword Aura]

[You have learned Sword Aura]

[Congratulations! You have been awarded the title 'Swordmaster']

[Advanced Sword Mastery]

[Description: Greatly improves your control with the sword by 30% and increases all damage dealt with swords by 50%. Your enemies will feel more pain from your sword attacks as your damage increases. Your sword techniques will also have more impact. Requires no activation.]

[Sword Aura]

[Mastery Level: 1]

[Description: Allows you to convert your spiritual energy into Sword Aura and treat it as though it's a real sword. Increases sword damage and sharpness. The effects increase with Mastery Level.]

"So this is Sword Aura, huh? I feel like I am surrounded by invisible swords..." Yuan looked at his hand that was protected by Sword Aura.

"Hmm? Isn't this kind of like Qi Manifestation?" He mumbled in a pondering voice.

"Who's there?" Yuan suddenly noticed a presence behind him and turned around.

"Eh? You're... Miss Lan?" Yuan immediately recognized her pretty face and unique azure-colored eyes.

However, there was something different about her this time. More precisely, her appearance— her clothes. They were ragged, almost like someone had

used a knife and slashed her clothes a dozen times until it turned into this sad state, and a lot of her skin was exposed by the holes in her clothes.

"Umm... Are you okay?" Yuan pointed at her shredded clothes, completely oblivious that he was the culprit.

Lan Yingying looked down with a nonchalant expression before speaking, "Never mind that. I want you to meet my family. Can you come with me now?"

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Chapter 313 - When Can We Expect A Child?

"You want me to meet your family? Why?" Yuan looked at Lan Yingying with wide eyes.

"Because I want to confirm something. Perhaps it might even have something to do with you being here," she said in a calm voice.

"Really?" Yuan's eyes flickered with excitement. Since she's the guardian of this place, and her family used to serve the swordmaster who marked this stone tablet, they might know something about the voice that beckoned him, perhaps even the faceless individual he saw outside the Mystic Realm.

Lan Yingying nodded and said, "It's only half an hour away from this place. Follow me."

She then turned around and walked out of the temple in a casual manner, acting as though her clothes weren't in such a shabby state.

Yuan didn't linger around and proceeded to follow her outside the temple.

After some time, he could no longer hold his curiosity and decided to ask her, "What happened to your clothes? Did you encounter a powerful magical beast on your way here?"

Lan Yingying looked at him without stopping her legs, and she said, "There are no magical beasts in this area. As for why my clothes are in this state—"

Lan Yingying raised her hand and pointed her finger at him.

"You're the one who made my clothes like this— your Sword Aura, to be exact."

"W-What! I am terribly sorry! I didn't mean to..." Yuan was shocked to hear that he was the cause of her ridiculous appearance.

"I know... You don't have to say anything. It was my fault for being so nosy and getting too close, anyways." Lan Yingying shrugged it off casually.

"Thank you, Miss Lan!" Yuan said to her, feeling relieved that she didn't blame him.

Half an hour later, they arrived at this spacious land in the middle of the dead forest, and at the center of this place was a large wooden cabin alongside a couple of smaller buildings.

"You live here?" Yuan raised his eyebrows. He didn't expect a young girl like Lan Yingying to live in a place like this, especially since she looked so noble and graceful, almost like a noble in a big family.

"Yes, and my grandparents," she said.

"Oho? What a surprise." An old man with long white hair and a medium white beard came out of the cabin before they could even approach it.

"Grandma, come look at this— look at what Ying'er brought home. It's a man! And our dear granddaughter even looks like a mess!" The old man suddenly began shouting out loud in a voice full of excitement.

"What?! A man?! Impossible!" Another voice quickly resounded, and a few seconds later, an old lady also came out of the house and stood beside the old man.

"Heavens! Look at her appearance! Looks like they had plenty of fun before coming back here!"

"I'm back, grandfather, grandmother." Lan Yingying said to them, acting like she didn't hear their loud words just now.

"Hey, boy. Are you my granddaughter's boyfriend? Where did you two meet? How long have you been dating? Have ya done 'that' yet?" The old man suddenly began bombarding Yuan with questions.

"Calm down, you old fool. What if you scare him away? This is the first time she brought home a man, too! I'll skin you alive, old fool." The old lady even smacked the old man's butt as she scolded him.

"Hello, young man. You can ignore this old fart. With that being said, when can we expect a child from you two?" The old lady spoke with a grin on her face.

Meanwhile, Yuan was left speechless by their weird questions.

"Grandfather, grandmother, stop joking around. This is a serious matter regarding the Lord's stone tablet." Lan Yingying said to them with a slight frown on her face.

"The Lord's stone tablet?"

Her grandparents' face suddenly became serious upon hearing her words.

"What about the Lord's stone tablet? Did something happen?" The old man then asked with a frown on his face.

Lan Yingying nodded her head before pointing at Yuan and speaking, "The Lord's stone tablet reacted to him, allowing him to absorb the Sword Aura left behind by the Lord."

"WHAT?!"

The both of them exclaimed in a shocked voice.

"D-Don't tell me he's the Lord's descendant?!" The old lady spoke in a trembling voice.

"I brought him here to see if that is the case or not." Lan Yingying said.

"Hmmm..."

After a moment of silence, the old man said, "Come inside first. We'll talk once we are feeling more comfortable."

The grandparents then entered the house.

"Let's go, Yuan." Lan Yingying said to him before going inside the house.

"..."

Although it felt weird to enter a stranger's home, Yuan didn't feel any malevolence from them and decided to trust them.

Once they were inside, Yuan sat around a large table with the others.

"Give me more context." The old man then said.

Lan Yingying nodded and proceeded to recall everything she knew— from her first meeting with Yuan two days ago to their second meeting today.

"I see... Can you tell me a little bit more about yourself, young man?" The old man then turned to look at Yuan.

Yuan nodded and said, "I came here with my fellow disciples, but we got separated on our way here, and before I knew it, I was in the forest. Then I heard this voice that beckoned me, so I followed it, and the voice led me to the temple."

"Hmmm..."

The grandparents pondered for a moment before speaking, "If you don't mind me asking... What is your purpose for coming to this place?"

"To be completely honest with you, I have no clue." Yuan shrugged.

The grandparents exchanged looks with each other, and the old lady asked him a moment later, "Young man... Did you perhaps come from the outside world?"

"Eh?" Yuan's eyes widened.

The people here are aware of the outside world? That they're currently inside the Mystic Realm? Just what is this place?

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Chapter 314 - Mystic Realm Natives

"What? You think we wouldn't know about the world outside the Mystic Realm when you outsiders come here every ten years?" The old man said.

And he continued, "You know, the people of this world— the natives... Our ancestors also used to live in the outside world, but they decided to live in this world instead, isolated from the outside world."

"Huh? But how's that possible? I thought we only have a month inside the Mystic Realm before we must leave?" Yuan spoke in a dazed voice.

"Hahaha... Sure, that's how the Mystic Realm works nowadays. However, that wasn't the case during the ancient times when people could enter the Mystic Realm at will and without any restrictions." The old man said.

And he continued, "The Mystic Realm changed when it got an owner—who turned this place into a massive trial of sorts, implementing the rules that you're experiencing now."

"Wow... I had no idea the Mystic Realm would have such a deep history. What about the people of this world? Can you guys leave the Mystic Realm?" Yuan asked after his initial awe.

The old lady shook her head and said, "Unfortunately, we're stuck in this world."

"Before the owner created the rules for this world, he'd asked everybody in this world if they wanted to leave or stay in this world, and at that time, our

ancestors, with full knowledge that they won't be able to leave this place ever again, decided to stay in here."

"There is no way out of this world— only a way inside, not including the time limit of 1 month." The old man continued.

"Don't you want to go outside?" Yuan suddenly asked.

"Not really. According to our ancestors, the spiritual energy in this world is much better than the spiritual energy outside. Although it's much smaller in this world, we'll get to live longer since we have a higher cultivation base, and there are not as many worldly conflicts here." The old lady explained.

"I guess the spiritual energy in this place is much more abundant than outside overall..." Yuan couldn't deny this since he'd experienced it for himself firsthand.

"To tell you the truth, not everyone in this world is like us, as most of the natives aren't very fond of outsiders, since many of them are jealous of your ability to leave this place. Therefore, it's best to keep your identity as an outsider hidden." The old man revealed to him, taking him by surprise.

"I see... Thank you for the heads up." Yuan nodded.

"Anyways, returning to the topic at hand... We believe you're a descendant from our Lord's bloodline in the outside world, and we would like to check your blood if you don't mind." The old lady said.

"I highly doubt it... But what if... What if I turn out to be a descendant?" Yuan asked, his interest piqued.

"Then we will serve you for the rest of our lives— at least until you have to leave the Mystic Realm." Lan Yingying said to him with a serious look on her face.

"Uhhh..." Yuan looked at them with a perplexed expression. They're going to serve him? That didn't feel right to him for some reason.

"How will you test my blood?" He still asked them a moment later.

"Oh, that's simple. You simply have to mix some of your blood with our blood to see if there's any reaction. If there's even the slightest reaction, it'll mean that you're the Lord's descendant." The old man explained.

"Are you willing?"

Yuan nodded.

Seeing his approval, the old man turned to look at Lan Yingying and said, "Go ahead. Drop some of your blood into this bottle."

"Yes, grandfather."

Lan Yingying retrieved a small knife from her spatial ring before cutting a decently large hole in her finger, startling Yuan with the amount of blood she squeezed into the bottle.

"Don't worry, we only need a drop of your blood." The old man laughed after seeing his nervous expression.

After Lan Yingying stopped pouring her blood into the bottle, she licked the wound on her finger, and Yuan watched as the cut on her finger instantly healed.

"Go ahead, young man." The old man handed the bottle to Yuan afterward.

Yuan nodded and retrieved his Starry Abyss before cutting a small wound on his thumb.

'A Soul Weapon?'

The old couple was shocked when they realized the treasure in Yuan's grasp, but they didn't say anything.

A few seconds later, Yuan dripped a large drop of his blood inside the blood, and everybody there watched for any reaction in anticipation.

One second... two seconds... three seconds...

Half a minute passed without any reaction, and the old man placed the bottle down and sighed.

"Unfortunately, you're not the Lord's descendant." The old man said in a sighing voice.

"I see..." Yuan nodded, feeling relieved for some reason.

"Well, even if you aren't the Lord's descendant, you're still a very talented young lad, learning Sword Aura as a Spirit Warrior. You definitely qualify to sow your seed inside our granddaughter." The old lady said with a grin on her face.

"Sow my seed in her? What?" Yuan was completely puzzled by their words.

"Don't mind them, Yuan. They've been like this ever since my parents died, and they're worried that our family's long legacy will end with me." Lan Yingying explained to him.

"Anyways, do you have any questions for them?" Lan Yingying then asked him.

Yuan nodded and said, "Do you know anything about the voice that beckoned me to the temple? And what about that faceless person I saw?"

"..."

However, the old couple didn't respond to him, and on their face was a gawking expression, their eyes filled with shock.

"What's the matter?" Yuan asked them.

"A-Are you sure about that? A faceless person?!" The old man asked him in a trembling voice.

Yuan nodded, "Yes. I'm sure. Do you know who that is?"

The old man swallowed nervously before speaking, "That... That is most likely the Lord!"

"Huh?" Yuan's eyes widened with surprise after learning this new information.

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Chapter 315 - Faceless Statue

"C-Can you please give some more description to this 'faceless person'? What kind of clothes was he wearing? What color was his hair? How long was his hair? How tall was he? What kind of aura did he emit?" The old man asked him in an anxious voice.

Yuan nodded his head before closing his eyes to recall the faceless person.

"He was wearing black clothes with a golden outline. He had long black hair that was nearly as long as his body, and he looked a little bit taller than the average adult. Probably around 74 inches if I had to take a guess. As for his aura... He definitely gave the feeling of a noble or something otherworldly."

"W-What about his sword?! Was he carrying a sword?!" The old man asked, his voice growing more excited as he spoke.

"A sword...?" Yuan pondered harder.

After a moment of silence, Yuan said, "Oh, yeah, I think he was carrying a sword on his back. However, it looked like an ordinary sword so I didn't pay too much attention to it."

"Hahaha! That's it! He definitely sounds like the Lord!" The old man said as he stood up.

"Come with me!" The old man then walked outside.

Yuan and the others followed him outside.

Once they were outside, the old man led them to a path that was behind the cabin. A few minutes later, they reached this small but empty area, and

standing in the middle of this area was a statue made of some kind of metallic material. However, the most surprising part about this statue was its face— or more precisely, its lack of a face.

Indeed, it was a statue of the faceless figure.

"This is..." Yuan was dumbstruck the moment his eyes laid on the statue.

"Is this the person that you saw?" The old man asked him afterward.

Yuan nodded in a dazed manner, "Yes... Although he looks slightly different, he is, without doubt, the faceless person I saw!"

Despite being a statute, it gave off a domineering aura, almost like it was a real person standing there.

"Although you're not the Lord's descendant, you're most likely related to him in some way since he beckoned you to the stone tablet." The old man said.

"Just who is this Lord person anyways?" Yuan asked, and he continued, "And why is he faceless even as a statue?"

"Let me answer your second question first. The Lord... Nobody has ever seen his face before, hence why his statue is faceless. Just like what you're doing right now, the Lord always wore a mask— ever since his first appearance to the day he disappeared from this world." The old man said.

"As for who the Lord is— we also don't know much about his existence except for the fact that he'd showed up one day out of the blue, exhibiting heaven-defying talents and obtaining admiration from countless people. Our ancestors were one of these people, hence why they decided to serve him. Also, he somehow managed to obtained control of the Mystic Realm, becoming its master."

"Oh? So he was the one who closed the Mystic Realm and turned it into a place of trials? Why did he do such a thing?" Yuan asked, his interest piqued.

"Nobody knows, honestly. The Lord was an eccentric person who exceeds all expectations... We will probably never know his true intentions..." The old man sighed.

"I see... Then do you know anything about the Mystic Pagoda?" Yuan decided to ask them since Senior Nie made it sound like an important place.

"The Mystic Pagoda? That's where the Lord used to live." The old lady said to him.

And she continued, "Don't tell me the outsiders are still trying to open it? They should give up already."

"Eh?"

Seeing the puzzlement in Yuan's eyes, the old lady explained, "Every ten years, the outsiders will try to open up the Mystic Pagoda, but it's useless. Only the owner of the Mystic Realm can enter that place, but nobody but the Lord knows how to do it. Even to this day, nobody else besides the Lord has managed to become the master of this place."

"Is that so..." Yuan mumbled in a low voice.

"Anyways, do you have any more questions? If not, why don't you and our granddaughter here go conceive a child or two? After all, you only have a month in this world." The old lady suddenly said to him with a smile on her face.

"What?" Yuan looked at the granny with wide eyes.

"Why are you still joking about that grandmother?" Lan Yingying shook her head in a calm manner.

"Joke? Do I look like I'm joking?" Her grandmother turned to look at her with a serious expression on her face.

Lan Yingying's eyes widened slightly at this.

"You... You're serious?" she mumbled in a dazed voice.

"Of course. This young man has extraordinary talents. He definitely qualifies to help us continue our lineage." The old lady said.

"Our legacy has lasted for hundreds of thousands of years. We're not going to let it end with you, Yingying." The old man also said with a profound look on his face.

"..."

The two old couple emitted a fearsome aura at this moment, causing both Yuan and Lan Yingying to shudder.

It was at this moment a loud and sharp ear-piercing cry suddenly resounded in the area, but it didn't sound like it came from a human.

"Che." The old man sneered with an annoyed look on his face. "They don't learn, do they?"

Then, to Yuan's surprise, the old man suddenly levitated off the ground and flew into the sky.

"A Spirit Grandmaster?!" Yuan exclaimed.

However, Yuan quickly realized that the aura coming from the old man surpassed even Feng Yuxiang who was a peak Spirit Grandmaster. In other words, there was a good chance this old man was a Spirit Lord!

A few moments later, a very large bird covered in black, metallic feathers, could be seen flying towards their direction, and it emitted a familiar aura—the aura of a Spirit Grandmaster.

"What on earth is that?!" Yuan was shocked by this large bird that was slightly larger than a football field.

However, the old man remained completely tranquil despite facing such an intimidating monster.

"Did you anger your master or something? Why else would he send you here—to your death?" The old man shook his head before lifting his hand

and pointing at the large bird, mumbling in a low voice.

"Sacred Fire."

Whoosh!

A massive rotating ball of sparkling white flames suddenly appeared in front of the old man's finger.

"Begone."

The old man released the ball of white flames, shooting it directly at the massive bird.

KRAAAAAAA

The large bird released a painful cry as the white flames engulfed its entire body instantly. However, the noises didn't last more than a few seconds as the white flames quickly consumed its massive body until even its ashes completely disappeared from this world.

After disintegrating the large bird, the old man returned to their side and spoke with an innocent smile on his face, acting like he'd just gotten rid of an insect and not a powerful magical beast, "Anyways, why don't the two of you go find a room and start working on that child? We don't have that much time, after all."

Chapter 316 - Unique Charisma

"Grandfather, we just met and are no different than strangers. How can you ask me to conceive a child with him? Not to mention our situation..." Lan Yingying said to him.

"So what if you're strangers? Your relationship won't matter regardless since he'll be leaving in a month whether you like it or not!" The old man said.

"Even if you say that... What about his opinion on this matter?" Lan Yingying turned to look at Yuan, who looked very confused about the current situation.

"Do we even need to ask him? Who could possibly refuse our beautiful granddaughter? And why do you seem so reluctant? If you don't continue our lineage, who will take care of the Lord's stone tablet in the future? Who will be here to greet the Lord when he returns?" The old man sighed.

"W-Wait a minute..." Yuan suddenly interrupted. "What do you mean by your last words? Hasn't it been hundreds of thousands of years since the Lord 'disappeared' from this place? Can a human even live that long?"

The old man chuckled after hearing his words, and he spoke a moment later, "Of course not— no human would be able to live that long. However, the Lord is not dead, and while we say he 'disappeared', the Lord merely left the Mystic Realm and hasn't returned since then. Although we don't know where he went or what he's doing outside, with his heaven-defying talents, we're certain that he could reach the peak of cultivation and become a real Immortal."

"True Immortals can live millions of years with ease, nor are they affected by the passage of time. They also can't die from natural causes such as diseases or old age, and the only way they can die is if someone kills them, but even that requires some effort."

"And as long as the Lord is alive, he'll definitely return to this world in the future. That's what he promised my ancestors right before he left, after all." The old man said with a confident smile on his face.

Yuan was speechless. He was simply amazed by their loyalty to this Lord person. If he had to wait hundreds of thousands of years, even potentially millions of years for someone to return, he would've probably lost faith long ago.

"Anyways, thank you for teaching me so much about this world, but I have to leave now, as I still need to regroup with my team," Yuan said to them a moment later.

"What? You're leaving already? But you still haven't done anything with our granddaughter! At least sow your seeds in her before you leave!" The old lady quickly said.

"Umm... I'm not exactly sure what you mean by that..." Yuan then said.

The old couple exchanged looks with each other. What kind of life has this young man been living that made him so innocent? What about his parents?

"Ahem!" The old man cleared his throat and said, "In other words... I want you and my granddaughter to have a child together."

Yuan's eyes widened with shock. While he doesn't know anything about giving birth since nobody has taught him about the subject, he at least knew how much responsibility it was to have children.

"B-But I won't be in this world in a month... And I don't think I am ready to bear so much responsibility..." Yuan said to them a moment later.

"It's fine even if you leave. We aren't asking for you to take responsibility, either. You simply need to impregnate our granddaughter so that our lineage will continue. We'll take care of everything else after that." The old lady said.

Yuan looked at the old couple for a moment before turning to look at Lan Yingying.

After a moment of silence, Yuan lowered his head and apologized to them, "I'm sorry, but if I ever have children, I want to be there for them. You see, even though I was adopted at a young age, I never knew my real parents or what they look like, and I don't want my own children to experience the same loneliness I felt before I was adopted. I hope you can understand..."

"..."

The old couple was left speechless by Yuan's words. As much as they wanted him to conceive a child with their granddaughter, they couldn't force him.

After a moment of silence, the old man nodded and said, "I see... I will also apologize if you felt pressured by us. If you don't want to, we won't force you."

"What a pity... We have been looking for someone like you for such a long time, too..." The old lady sighed in a regretful voice.

The old man then said, "Yingying, go show the young man the way out and take him to the nearest city. Although there should be no magical beasts around this place, there are magical beasts roaming outside, and they might be a little too much for him to handle even if he understands Sword Aura."

"Okay." Lan Yingying nodded.

"Thank you, Seniors. It was nice meeting you." Yuan said to them.

"Just call us Grandpa Lan and Grandma Lan. I am also glad that we got to meet a genius like you since it gives us a feeling of what our ancestors

might have felt when they met the Lord for the first time," said Grandpa Lan.

"If you decide to change your mind about having a child with our granddaughter before leaving this place, you can come back here at any time. My granddaughter will always be available for you." Grandma Lan said to him.

Sometime later, Lan Yingying led Yuan away from the cabin and towards the direction of the unnamed temple.

"Isn't it strange, grandpa?" Grandma Lan spoke after Yuan left.

"What?"

"How we don't dislike him even though he's a human. In fact, I even liked him very much," she said.

"I know how you feel, grandma. There was just something attractive about him. Perhaps it's his unique charisma. I wonder if this is what our ancestors felt when they met the Lord. If so, I can totally understand why they decided to serve him." Grandpa Lan said with a smile on his face, and the two of them returned to the cabin shortly after.

Chapter 317 - Blue Star

"Let me see the stone tablet one more time before we leave this place," Yuan said to Lan Yingying when they returned to the temple.

Lan Yingying nodded her head, and they climbed the staircase, entering the temple a moment later.

Yuan approached the stone tablet. Once he was directly in front of it, he clasped his hands together and bowed to the stone tablet.

"I don't know why you called me here, and I might never find out, but thank you for showing me this place, allowing me to learn Sword Aura." Yuan paid his respect to the stone tablet.

After Yuan lifted his head, he continued, "Maybe I'll even see you in the upper heavens when I decide to ascend this world. At that time, I'll thank you properly."

Sometime later, Lan Yingying led Yuan away from the temple.

As they walked, Lan Yingying suddenly asked him, "Hey... What's the outside world like?"

"Eh? The outside world? It hasn't been long since I came to this place so I can't really tell you what's different... sorry," he said.

"Don't mind it," she shook her head with a somewhat gloomy feeling in her eyes.

After a moment of silence, Yuan asked her, "Do you want to go outside?"

A profound glint appeared in Lan Yingying's eyes, and she nodded her head, "I'd be lying if I say I am not curious about the outside world."

"I think it's unfair..." Yuan suddenly said.

And he continued, "How your ancestors' decision to stay in this world also affected their children and so on. If someone wants to leave this place, they should have the choice to do so— at least that's what I believe."

A small smile appeared on Lan Yingying's pretty face after hearing Yuan's words.

"Then why don't you try to become the Master of this place and set us all free?" Lan Yingying suddenly said.

"But nobody knows how the Lord became the Master, right? Even if I want to help you, I don't know what I should be doing."

"The Mystic Pagoda. Perhaps you'll find some clues there."

"Where is the Mystic Pagoda?" Yuan then asked.

Lan Yingying lifted her hand and pointed to a certain direction in the sky.

"Do you see that blue star? If you follow it, it'll lead you to the Mystic Pagoda."

Following her fingers, Yuan's eyes widened with surprise when he realized what she was talking about.

"What! How could there be stars in the sky already? The sun hasn't even begun to set yet!" Yuan exclaimed in a shocked voice.

"That star is a special star. You can see it throughout the day no matter if it's day or night."

"I see... Thank you..."

Yuan turned to look at Lan Yingying, and he continued in a somewhat awkward voice, "By the way, are you sure you want to continue walking around in that appearance? What if someone sees you?"

Lan Yingying looked down at her own clothes that were still torn, and she said, "Oh, right. I nearly forgot."

Lan Yingying suddenly stopped walking and proceeded to remove her clothes on the spot, taking Yuan by surprise.

"You could've at least warned me..." Yuan instinctively turned around to give her some privacy.

"Okay, I am done." Lan Yingying said a moment later, sounding very calm despite just changing her clothes in front of a man, and they continued walking shortly after, acting like nothing just happened.

"How far away is the nearest city?" Yuan asked her after walking for an hour without seeing anything civilization in sight.

"About seven days, give or take," she responded in a calm manner.

"Seven days?! That's an entire week!" Yuan's eyes widened with shock. Just where the heck did the Mystic Realm take him?

At this rate, he won't regroup with the others until there are only a few days left in the Mystic Realm.

"We're in the most isolated area in this world so there's nothing we can do about it." Lan Yingying said.

"I see... I'm sorry for making you go through the trouble, and thank you..." Yuan said to her.

"It's okay. I have nothing better to do, anyway." Lan Yingying said.

"What do you normally do besides cleaning the stone tablet?" Yuan decided to ask her.

"Cultivate... and hunting ignorant magical beasts that dare to enter our area without permission, just like that Onyx Crow." Lan Yingying said.

Yuan swallowed nervously after hearing her words. After all, he also entered their place without any permission.

Lan Yingying noticed his weird behavior and said, "Don't worry, we are forbidden from harming humans unless they threaten us or show aggression first. This is a rule set by the Lord."

"I see..."

Yuan nodded, and they continued to walk in silence for a couple of hours until Yuan suddenly realized something.

"Oh no! I completely forgot about Meixiu!" Yuan stopped walking and exclaimed.

"Meixiu?" Lan Yingying raised her eyebrows.

"Give me a moment! I'll be back in a bit!" Yuan said to her before logging off the game.

"Meixiu?! Are you here?" Yuan called out for her when he logged off.

"I'm here, Yuan," she quickly responded.

"I'm sorry! I was too absorbed in the game and completely forgot to log off again!" He said to her.

"Don't worry about it," she said to him.

"Let me go warm up your breakfast."

After warming up the soup, she fed it to Yuan.

"Once again, I'm really sorry."

"It's okay, really. There's nothing else for me to do, anyway."

Yuan then said, "If you want, you can play the game with Feng Feng and the others. You don't have to wait for me to finish the Mystic Realm since that's going to take a while."

"Even though I am doing nothing but watching the participants, I enjoy it. It feels like I am watching a movie or something, and the others are always engaged in something." Meixiu said.

"W-Wait a moment... You can watch us from the outside?" Yuan was surprised when he heard this.

"Yes, we can see everything the participants are doing using this treasure. However, for some reason, you're not shown, so we cannot see where you are or what you're doing." Meixiu said to him.

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Chapter 318 - Earth Dragon

"If you can see the participants, does this mean you know where the other two disciples are at? Where are they? I need to regroup with them as soon as possible, and it would help a lot if I know where to go." Yuan said to her.

"Unfortunately, while we can see them, we don't know their exact location, especially since they have spent almost every minute in the same location ever since they entered the Mystic Realm, increasing their cultivation base," Meixiu said.

"Once I learn of their location, I'll let you know immediately," she then added.

"Okay. Thank you. I have to return to the game now. There's somebody waiting for me."

"Eh? Who are you with?"

"A native from the Mystic Realm. I met her on the first day, and she's currently helping me reach the nearest city. However, it's going to take a week..." Yuan sighed.

"Anyways, I'm going back now. Thank you for dinner, it was amazing as always."

Sometime later, Yuan returned to Cultivation Online whilst Meixiu went to clean up before going back inside the game as well.

"Sorry for making you wait, Miss Lan. I'm back." Yuan said to her, who was just standing there with a dazed look on her face.

Once she saw Yuan, Lan Yingying nodded her head and continued walking like nothing was out of the ordinary.

After walking for an hour, Lan Yingying suddenly said, "Do you want to run? It'll shorten the time we need to get to the city by almost half depending on how fast we run."

Yuan nodded, "If you don't mind."

Thus, the two of them began speeding up and running across the empty grassland, following the direction of the blue star in the darkened sky.

A couple of hours later, once the sky was completely dark and flickering with stars, Lan Yingying suddenly halted and said, "Stop."

Yuan quickly stopped and asked her, "What's the matter?"

"There's a magical beast ahead. First level Spirit Master. I'll handle it." Lan Yingying said to him.

"Wait a moment." Yuan suddenly stopped her, and he continued a moment later, "Can I handle this? I want to try out my Sword Aura."

"You want to fight a Spirit Master as a Spirit Warrior? You're not even halfway to the peak of Spirit Warrior..." Lan Yingying looked at him with wide eyes, almost like she was looking at a crazy person.

"I just want to hit it once with my Sword Aura. If it doesn't work out, I'll let you handle it." Yuan then said.

"Okay..." Lan Yingying nodded her head.

The two of them continued moving shortly after, but they stopped running.

About ten minutes later, they could see a massive reptile with a large jaw that resembled a certain type of dinosaur, and it was standing on two legs, almost like a T-Rex. Furthermore, there appeared to be rocks growing on its skin, kind of like an armor.

"What kind of magical beast is that?" Yuan couldn't help but ask her.

"That's an Earth Dragon. They are incredibly tough and powerful. One would think they are slow due to their large figure, but they are actually the opposite and quite nimble." Lan Yingying said.

And she continued, "If you want to hit it, you'll need to take it by surprise. However, you only have one chance. If your attack fails for whatever reason, I will deal with it."

Yuan nodded and took a deep breath before retrieving the Empyrean Overlord from his body.

"T-That sword..." Lan Yingying couldn't take her eyes away from the Empyrean Overlord for some reason after seeing it, almost like there was something about it that was attracting her on a spiritual level.

Meanwhile, Yuan took a deep breath before displaying his movement technique, closing the distance between him and the Earth Dragon very quickly.

The Earth Dragon noticed Yuan almost immediately, but when it realized Yuan's pathetic cultivation base compared to its own, the Earth Dragon scoffed at Yuan's reckless behavior inwardly and didn't even bother trying to defend against Yuan's attack since it was confident in its own toughness.

Once he was close enough, Yuan's eyes flickered with viciousness, and his body exploded with Sword Aura.

"?!?!"

The contempt in the Earth Dragon's eyes immediately disappeared, replaced with intense fear.

"Bloody Sword Strike!"

The Empyrean Overlord emitted a domineering red aura, and Yuan swung it at the Earth Dragon without holding back.

BOOM!

The Earth Dragon was frozen from shock and felt suppressed by the sword's overwhelming pressure.

A split second later, the Empyrean Overlord reached the Earth Dragon's tough skin before cleaving its massive body in half with ease, like a sharp knife going through tofu.

However, the Empyrean Overlord didn't stop after cleaving the Earth Dragon and continued to slam onto the ground, creating a massive fissure in the ground that spread out meters into the distance, resembling tree roots.

Lan Yingying's jaw dropped when she witnessed the overwhelming prowess displayed by Yuan, who was merely a fifth-level Spirit Warrior.

'Heavens! What is his body made of?! How can a Spirit Warrior have such strength?' Lan Yingying cried inwardly.

Forget about killing the Earth Dragon in one hit, she didn't even expect Yuan to penetrate the Earth Dragon's defenses!

'Is he really this powerful, or is it because of that mythical sword?' Lan Yingying wondered to herself.

After killing the Earth Dragon, Yuan went to check if it left behind its monster core, but alas, it was empty.

A few moments later, Lan Yingying approached Yuan and looked at the Earth Dragon's corpse with a weird glint on her eyes before swallowing nervously.

"Yuan, what kind of sword is that?" Lan Yingying asked him a moment later.

"The Empyrean Overlord? It's my Soul Weapon," he said.

"Soul Weapon? What about the dagger? It gave off a similar aura."

"That's also a Soul Weapon. I have two," he calmly responded.

"Two Soul Weapons..." Lan Yingying was speechless.

After a moment of silence, she asked him, "By the way, if you don't mind, can I see that sword? I am getting some kind of feeling from it, and I don't know why."

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Chapter 319 - Unknown Entity

"Sure. Go ahead." Yuan nodded his head, not hesitating to hand the Empyrean Overlord to Lan Yingying since he trusted her, and even if she wanted to steal it, the Soul Weapon will automatically return to him if it gets too far away from him.

"Here you go." Yuan handed the sword to her in a casual manner.

"T-This sword is... so heavy!" Lan Yingying was taken by surprise by the weight of the Empyrean Overlord, nearly falling over trying to hold it at first.

"Oh, right, I forgot about that. It weighs about 1,000 jins naturally." Yuan had forgotten about its weight after handling it like a tree branch for so long.

"Where did you obtain such a treasure? And do you know its background?" she then asked, her gaze staring at the beautiful sword with a somewhat mesmerizing look.

"Apparently, it was found in a Legacy Tomb five hundred years ago. As for its background... It used to be wielded by a Sword Emperor." Yuan recalled what Feng Yuxiang told him and the Empyrean Overlord's description.

"Sword... Emperor? Do you, by any chance, know the name of this Sword Emperor?" Lan Yingying asked.

"No, I don't."

"I see..." Lan Yingying mumbled.

"Thank you for letting me see it."

She handed the Empyrean Overlord back to Yuan a moment later.

"Let's continue moving." Yuan then said.

"Wait a moment." Lan Yingying suddenly said, and she pointed at the Earth Dragon's corpse, "Since you killed the Earth Dragon, its corpse obviously belongs to you, but do you think I can buy it off you?"

"Eh? You want this Earth Dragon's corpse?" Yuan raised his eyebrows, wondering why she wanted it.

"If you want it, you can take it. Also, you don't have to pay me." Yuan said, as he doesn't have any uses for the corpse, nor does he plan on selling its materials.

"Really? Are you sure? An Earth Dragon's corpse will fetch a lot of money if you sell it..." She asked him just to be sure.

Yuan nodded, "It's the least I can do for you, who's helping me reach the nearest city."

"Thank you very much..." Lan Yingying bowed to him before collecting the Earth Dragon's corpse with her spatial ring.

Shortly after, they continued to run across the grassland, encountering a couple more magical beasts in a few hours.

Of course, Yuan wanted to fight these magical beasts despite having a lower cultivation base in comparison.

And just like the Earth Dragon, these Spirit Master magical beasts looked at Yuan with contempt when they realized he was only a Spirit Warrior, lowering their guards.

However, these magical beasts immediately regretted underestimating Yuan's low cultivation base the moment he released his Sword Aura, and they could only powerlessly stare at Yuan as he slashes their body into two parts.

After Yuan killed these magical beasts, Lan Yingying would collect their corpses, almost like a trash collector picking up trash on the sidewalk.

"Do magical beasts not drop monster cores around here or something? I've killed over a dozen of them without a single monster core!" Yuan complained after some time.

"The higher cultivation a magical beast, the less likely they'll drop a monster core." Lan Yingying said to him.

"Really? That doesn't make any sense, but alas..." Yuan sighed.

Once the sun began peeking at the horizon, Yuan logged off the game to eat breakfast prepared by Meixiu.

"How are you doing in the Mystic Realm? Xiao Hua wanted to know." Meixiu said to him afterward.

"I'm still making my way to the nearest city. I've also been encountering more and more magical beasts the closer we get to the city. However, you don't have to worry since I can deal with them easily, especially ever since I've learned Sword Aura."

"I understand. I'll let them know."

Once she returned to the game, Meixiu relayed Yuan's situation to Xiao Hua and the others.

"What? Sword Aura?!" Long Yijun and the others expressed great shock after hearing this news.

"So Brother Yuan finally learned Sword Aura, huh?" Xiao Hua already knew that he would learn Sword Aura. It was just a matter of when.

Meanwhile, Yuan continued to follow the blue star in the sky with Lan Yingying.

"We should arrive in the city by tomorrow afternoon," Lan Yingying said to him.

"Okay."

After running for a couple of hours without stopping, Lan Yingying suddenly felt a cold shiver run down her spine, causing her to stop running, and she shouted in a panicked voice, "Yuan! Stop!"

"Eh? What happened? Another magical beast?" Yuan stopped and asked her.

However, when he turned around and saw the nervous look on Lan Yingying's face— even though she had remained relatively calm from their previous encounters with magical beasts— he realized something was amiss.

"It's worse than a magical beast! We need to get away from this place as soon as possible!" Lan Yingying said to him.

"Get away? From what?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

And before Lan Yingying could respond to him, a deep voice suddenly resounded.

"The little princess is together with a human? What an unusual sight."

BOOM!

The ground shook as a figure suddenly descended from the sky and landed about a hundred meters away from Yuan and Lan Yingying's location.

"What the heck is that?" Yuan's eyes widened with surprise when he saw this 'person' and its unique appearance, not to mention its tyrannical aura that was unlike anything he's experienced before.

This entity was standing on two tall legs like a human, and it also had the body of a human. However, this human-like figure had glowing red skin and a single black horn directly in the center of its forehead. The sclera of its eyes was pitch black with its iris and pupils bright red. Furthermore, it had long sharp ears, sharp fingernails that resembled claws, and long black hair. If one looked closely, there was also a red crystal implanted in the

middle of its chest. If one had to describe this entity with a single word, that word would be demonic.

"Where are you going with this human, little princess?" The demonic being spoke with a large, diabolic smile on its face, showing its two rows of sharp white teeth.

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Chapter 320 - Demon

"Miss Lan, what is that thing? It can even speak!" Yuan was more amazed by this unknown entity's existence than feeling fearful of it.

"You've never heard of a demon before?" Lan Yingying looked at him with surprise.

"A demon? That thing? This is my first time hearing about them, much less seeing one." Yuan said, and he continued, "How are they any different compared to magical beasts?"

"They're vastly superior to magical beasts overall. Just like how magical beasts are stronger than human cultivators at the same cultivation level, demons are stronger than magical beasts and by a huge margin as well. A Spirit Apprentice demon can even defeat a Spirit Warrior cultivator with ease." Lan Yingying explained to him.

"Furthermore, they cannot be killed by normal means and are essentially immortal since they can survive most injuries, even if you put a hole in their heart..."

"What? Such powerful entities exist? How come nobody talks about them outside?" Yuan was speechless.

"I can't tell you since I don't know what it's like outside, but in this world, they are very infamous for their brutality and tremendous strength. However, they are also very rare, and most people live their entire lives without even seeing one."

"Then I guess we're super lucky to encounter one right now?" Yuan asked.

"Hey, what are you two talking about? I also want to join in on the conversation." The demon suddenly said to them. However, it remained standing there, seemingly unwilling to approach them for some reason.

"How are you unaffected by the Lord's Sword Aura? You demons shouldn't be able to get this close to the Divine Forest." Lan Yingying spoke with a frown on her face.

The demon laughed before speaking, "It's all thanks to your parents. Thanks to their blood, we've gained some resistance to the Sword Aura, but this is the furthest I can go for now. Sooner or later, we'll be able to enter the Divine Forest and consume you and those old bastards."

Lan Yingying gritted her teeth in anger after hearing the demon mention her parents, and she lifted her arm with her Spirit Master cultivation fully activated.

"Shut up! Sacred Fire!" She shouted.

A ball of white flames appeared in front of her palms before flying at the demon.

However, despite seeing the ball of flames flying at it, the demon didn't even bother to move and remained standing there with a nonchalant look on its face.

The white flames engulfed the demon a moment later, but it didn't show any reactions.

"You've improved, little princess. However, compared to those old bastards, your Sacred Fire is still too weak to do any real harm to our bodies, much less kill us." The demon spoke as it bathed in her flames casually.

A few moments later, the white flames disappeared on their own, leaving behind minor burn marks on the demon's red skin. However, these injuries immediately healed within seconds as well.

"Miss Lan... you..." Instead of paying attention to the demon, Yuan was fully focused on Lan Yingying at this moment, mostly because her appearance had experienced some changes.

It wasn't anything shocking, but Lan Yingying's black hair had suddenly turned pure white, and her azure-colored eyes turned into a beautiful pink color.

Lan Yingying's minor transformation reminded him of Feng Yuxiang's transformation when her hairs and eyes changed colors after consuming his blood.

However, it didn't immediately occur to Yuan that Lan Yingying could be a magical beast like Feng Yuxiang since he thought Feng Yuxiang was unique as a Divine Beast and a phoenix, not to mention her curse, hence why she could transform into a human.

The demon suddenly spoke, "Don't worry, little princess. I didn't come here to kill you today. I'm here to relay a message from our Demon Lord, who said he'll let you live if you become his woman. If you don't, the Demon Clan will raid the Divine Forest in two weeks when we fully absorb your parents' blood."

"I'd rather die than to become that bastard's plaything!" Lan Yingying spoke with a fierce look on her face.

"Don't be so quick to make up your mind. You have two weeks to decide." The demon shrugged.

Then it turned to look at Yuan and continued to speak, "As for you, human... I won't let you go so easily. If you want to continue, you'll have to kill—"

In the middle of the demon's sentence, it was forced to stop speaking when a gaping hole suddenly appeared in its head, shocking Lan Yingying who had no idea what just happened.

The demon collapsed onto the ground in a lifeless manner.

"W-What happened?!" she exclaimed.

The next second, a dagger appeared out of thin air and hovered directly beside Yuan.

"That's your Soul Weapon! It can turn invisible?!" Lan Yingying was left speechless by the Starry Abyss's ridiculous ability.

"Yes." Yuan nodded with a calm look on his face, and he said, "I hope you don't mind my actions just now. That demon is clearly very dangerous, and it made you cry, so I decided to take care of it."

Lan Yingying looked at him with a loose jaw, not realizing that tears had formed by her eyes.

But alas, one cannot kill a demon with raw strength.

"Take care of me? A mere Spirit Warrior human? Hahaha! That's the funniest thing I've heard all year long!"

The demon's voice suddenly returned, taking Yuan by surprise.

"What the heck? It's still not dead even with an injury like that?" Yuan turned to look at the demon with a surprised face, and sure enough, it was standing again.

The gaping hole in its face also began to close back up, and in just a few moments, the demon healed fully.

"I'll admit that you'd managed to surprise me with that invisible attack just now. However, no matter how many times you open a hole in my face, you won't be able to kill me." The demon looked at Yuan with immense contempt in its gaze, almost like it was looking at an insect and not a human.

Chapter 321 - Three Free Attacks

"This is indeed quite troublesome. How can I kill that thing if it can survive even with a hole in its face?" Yuan sighed.

"I'm sorry, Yuan, but let's give up on going to the city for now and return to my grandparents to see if there's anything we can do about this situation. Although I have the power to defeat that demon, I don't have the power to kill it." Lan Yingying said to him.

"Wait a second, Miss Lan. You mentioned Sword Aura. Are demons afraid of Sword Aura or something? Maybe I can still..."

However, Lan Yingying shook her head and said, "No, the demons are not afraid of Sword Aura in general. Instead, they are specifically afraid of the Lord's Sword Aura. Before leaving this world, the Lord created these Sword Aura barriers around every city and the Divine Forest to protect them from the demons."

"As for why they're afraid of the Lord's Sword Aura... It's simply because the Lord's Sword Aura is so powerful that if a demon touches it, they will be destroyed until there's nothing left of them. No matter how powerful their regeneration abilities may be, if you destroy their bodies until there's not even a hair left, there won't be anything to regenerate from."

"I see... Then are there any more methods that can be used to kill demons?" Yuan asked.

"Besides completely erasing their existence, you need techniques with divine attributes such as my Sacred Fire."

"Techniques, huh?" Yuan mumbled.

"Hm?"

He suddenly recalled the Heaven-grade technique he'd learned at Myriad of Techniques— the Demon Sealing Strike.

"What about sealing demons? Can we seal them with techniques?" Yuan then asked.

"Demon sealing techniques? Those are incredibly rare and hard to learn, but yes, sealing a demon is akin to killing them." Lan Yingying nodded.

"I understand. Let me fight this demon. I think I'll be able to defeat it." Yuan said to her as he retrieved the Empyrean Overlord.

"What?! You want to fight that demon?! Don't do it! It has the strength of a peak Spirit Master, and you don't meet the requirements to kill it!"

"It's okay. I just want to try something." Yuan said with a smile on his face.

"Oh? You're approaching me?" The demon was pleasantly surprised when Yuan began walking towards it.

"Don't tell me that you're planning on fighting me— a demon?" The grin on the demon's face grew wider.

"That's right," Yuan responded with a calm look on his face, and he continued, "I won't be able to defeat you unless I get closer."

"HAHAHAHA! You're truly an amusing human! Normally, when a human sees me, they turn and run the opposite direction while shitting their own pants!"

After laughing for a moment, the demon suddenly stopped and narrowed its eyes at Yuan with a vicious expression.

"With that being said, who the fuck do you think you are, human? Do you really think you can defeat me when you couldn't kill me with a surprise attack? This is why I despise humans. They're incredibly arrogant and stupid at the same time." The demon looked at Yuan with clear disdain.

Yuan didn't respond to the demon this time, and he continued to approach it with a resolute expression on his face.

Seeing this, the demon took a few steps back and said, "Very well. I commend your bravery even if it might be stupidity, so I'll give you three free attacks."

"Then I won't be humble and accept these three attacks—"

Yuan suddenly activated his movement technique and appeared in front of the demon with the Empyrean Overlord raised high in the sky.

"Bloody Sword Strike!"

Despite the powerful aura emitted by the Empyrean Overlord, the demon remained standing there with its arms crossed and without batting an eyelid.

BOOM!

The Empyrean Overlord cleaved the demon into two separate parts from the head down.

Plop.

The demon collapsed on the ground again.

However, a few moments later, as though its body was made of liquid, the demon's separated body combined into one whole part, returning to its original state without a single injury on its body.

"You have two more attacks, human." The demon spoke with an arrogant grin on its face, knowing very well that even if it gave Yuan 1,000 free strikes, it still wouldn't be defeated.

"Heaven Splitting Sword Strike!"

Yuan wasted no time activating his second and strongest attack, sending a massive beam that was also mixed with Sword Aura at the demon.

The demon reacted this time, as it could sense a dreadful feeling from the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike, and it quickly dodged to the side, avoiding half of the attack.

However, the other half of the attack had completely disintegrated half of the demon's body, giving it quite a scare, causing it to sweat a little.

Lan Yingying's eyes widened with shock when she witnessed the demon retreating and the damage Yuan's second attack dealt to it.

'If that demon hadn't dodged the second attack, its entire body would've disappeared as if it had touched the Lord's Sword Aura! What a powerful sword technique!' Lan Yingying could feel her blood heating up afterward, and she began feeling hopeful that perhaps Yuan could really defeat it!

"Why did you dodge my attack just now?" Yuan asked the demon with a calm look on his face, and he continued, "I thought you were absolutely confident in your body's regenerating abilities? I guess you're not invincible, after all."

"You... You fucking brat... A mere human... How dare you!" A tyrannical aura exploded from the demon's body as its facial expression twisted with anger after feeling a burning sensation on its face from Yuan's words.

"What are you doing? I still have one more attack. Are you going to break your own words?" Yuan said.

"Hahaha! So what if I break my words? I am a fucking demon!" The demon laughed as it suddenly rushed at Yuan while spreading its claw-like hands.

"I'm going to rip your fucking limbs apart, drink your blood, and crunch on your bones, human!"

Chapter 322 - Demon Sealing Strike

Yuan immediately used his movement technique to dodge the demon's fast but seemingly simple claw attacks.

Whoosh!

After dodging a couple of attacks, Yuan retaliated with the Starry Abyss that had returned to being invisible.

The Starry Abyss tore another hole in the demon's face, but the demon continued to attack Yuan without falling.

"Are you incapable of learning, human?! You can't kill me no matter how many holes you bore in my body!"

However, Yuan ignored the demon's words and continued to attack it with the Starry Abyss, and in just a couple of minutes, he'd bore over a hundred holes on the demon's body.

'Is there no limit to its regenerating abilities?' Yuan wondered inwardly as he casually dodged the demon's claw attacks.

"Blood Spear!"

The demon suddenly created a long spear from its own blood before thrusting it at Yuan's face.

"Whoa!"

Yuan was slightly surprised by the spear, but he'd still managed to dodge it.

"I've had enough of you, damn human! Die!"

The demon created a dozen more spears that levitated in the air like the Starry Abyss.

[Flying Blood Spears!]

The demon pointed at Yuan, and a dozen spears suddenly flew at Yuan with extreme speed.

[Heaven Splitting Sword Strike!]

Yuan swung his sword once, destroying all of the spears simultaneously and erasing one of the demon's arms temporarily.

Seeing that its attack had failed, the demon continued to attack Yuan aggressively with the spear.

Ding! Ding! Clang!

Yuan defended himself with the Empyrean Overlord whilst attacking the demon with the Starry Abyss, waiting for the perfect opportunity to use the Demon Sealing Strike. However, the demon completely ignored the Starry Abyss and focused on attacking Yuan.

Meanwhile, Lan Yingying watched their intensive fight from a place where the demon cannot enter with a dazed expression on her face.

This is her first time seeing a human fight a demon and on such an equal standing. Even though demons are known for being insanely powerful, this demon appears to be struggling against a human cultivator who is only a Spirit Warrior!

"Stop running away! What are you, a cockroach?!" The demon exclaimed in an agitated voice when it realized that it couldn't defeat this human's profound movement techniques.

"If you don't want me to dodge then you should probably stop attacking me." Yuan casually responded.

"Like hell! I'll fucking kill you at all cost!" The demon shouted as he continued his endless wave of assaults.

"And you humans have limited energy! Unlike us demons, you're useless once your spiritual energy runs out, and you'll be no different than a mortal with no powers!"

Lan Yingying then warned him, "Yuan! You must finish this fight as soon as possible! The longer you fight a demon the more disadvantaged you are! Demons have nearly unlimited stamina and spiritual energy! You won't outlast him in endurance!"

"Why don't you come out here and help your human friend, little princess? However, I can't promise you that I won't accidentally eat you as well! Hahaha!" The demon provoked her.

"It's okay, Miss Lan. You don't have to worry about me. It won't be long before I defeat this demon." Yuan then said.

"I'd like to see you try!" The demon coldly snorted. While it was afraid of Yuan's Heaven Splitting Sword Strike, it was confident that Yuan wouldn't be able to use this technique too many times since it looked like it would consume a lot of spiritual energy.

Furthermore, the technique itself was easy to dodge as long as one remains vigilant, and as long as it doesn't hit its entire body, it'll be able to regenerate itself.

Yuan and the demon clashed against each other hundreds of times over the next few minutes, and once they were beginning to get into the rhythm, Yuan's aura suddenly exploded, and a pressurizing aura appeared around them, restricting the demon's movements.

[Heavenly Domain!]

The demon was taken by surprise by this mysterious pressure that slowed down its movements by a fair amount.

"What is this uncomfortable feeling?!"

However, slowing down the demon's movements was just a ploy to distract its attention and also the beginning of Yuan's plan.

"Hey! Demon!"

Yuan suddenly called out to it, causing it to subconsciously turn to look at him.

The moment the demon's gaze met with Yuan's eyes, his eyes turned golden and assaulted the demon with an invisible mental attack that was unlike anything the demon has experienced before.

The world suddenly turned dark for the demon, and all the demon could focus on at this moment was a pair of majestic eyes from an unfathomable existence hovering behind Yuan that looked down at it as though it was a mere ant.

"W-What the fuck are you?! You're not human!"

The demon mistook Yuan as a monster in human skin when it experienced the Dragon's Gaze, and it feared for its life for the first time.

However, Yuan didn't say anything and took this chance to attack the demon when it was frozen from fear.

[Demon Sealing Strike!]

Yuan stabbed the Empyrean Overlord that was emitting an ancient aura directly in the demon's chest, not noticing the symbols that had appeared on the sword's blade.

"Huh?"

The demon didn't feel any pain, only a numbed feeling, and it didn't realize that it had a sword piercing its body until it looked down and saw the massive sword between its chest.

"What do you think you're doing? You really don't learn—" The demon halted its sentence when it realized something was amiss—that its body was getting stiffer by the second.

The demon looked down again for the second time, and to its surprise, the wound around the sword was actually transforming! It was turning into stone!

"W-What is this?! What did you just do to me?!" The demon roared out loud and attacked Yuan in a panicked manner, but it struggled to release any strength.

Yuan kicked the demon in the stomach and pulled out the Empyrean Overlord from its body simultaneously before speaking in a calm voice, "Who knows, but I hope this demon sealing technique works on you."

"D-D-Demon sealing technique?! Why do you know something like that?! Don't tell me you're a descendant of the Demon Sealing Clan?!" The demon exclaimed while it kneeled on the ground powerlessly, feeling its body getting weaker as the petrifying effect from its wound spread throughout its body.

"Demon Sealing Clan? Never heard of them before. I learned this technique from a technique store some time ago." Yuan calmly responded, feeling quite happy that the technique appeared to be working perfectly against this demon.

"Curse you! I curse you, damn human!" The demon shouted loudly, and it felt an intense urge to rip Yuan to pieces, but alas, all four of its limbs and the majority of its body had turned to stone.

"If I ever get out of this seal, I will fucking kill you—!"

The demon's shouting halted when its mouth turned into stone, and a few more seconds later, the rest of the demon became petrified, transforming into a stone statue completely.

"Yuan... you... you really sealed the demon?" Lan Yingying approached him and the petrified demon sometime later with clear disbelief on her face.

"I hope so," he said.

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Chapter 323 - Demon Slayer

"What should we do with this sealed demon now, Miss Lan? How long do you think it'll be sealed for? And is there anything else we can do?" Yuan asked her afterward. It would be disastrous if the demon becomes unsealed a few days later if he doesn't take care of it properly now. However, he also didn't want to accidentally break the seal.

"It depends on how powerful your sealing technique is. Looking at it right now, the demon should remain sealed for a few hundred years." Lan Yingying looked at the fully petrified demon with a feeling of awe and admiration for Yuan, who sealed a demon as a Spirit Warrior.

"However, I think you should still take care of it entirely. You know that technique you used during your second free strike? Do you think you can completely obliterate the demon with it?" Lan Yingying then asked him.

"It won't break the seal if I hit it in this state?" Yuan asked just to make sure.

"It'll be fine. Even if your attack doesn't kill it, the seal won't be undone, and the demon won't be able to regenerate until the seal is completely gone, so you can take your time killing it. That's why demons are so afraid of sealing techniques." Lan Yingying explained to him.

"I see... Okay, I'll destroy it completely so it won't be able to cause any more trouble for you in the future." Yuan nodded before distancing himself from the sealed demon.

Once he was far enough, Yuan held the Empyrean Overlord in front of him and took his time to gather his spiritual energy.

Lan Yingying's eyes widened when she saw this and realized that Yuan's previous Heaven Splitting Sword Strike wasn't at its full power despite showing immense strength— enough to kill a demon.

At this moment, Yuan's body was gushing with Sword Aura, and the sword in his grasp was glowing a beautiful golden color.

[Heaven Splitting Sword Strike!]

Once he'd gathered enough spiritual energy, Yuan released his ultimate attack at the demon and completely covered its entire figure this time.

Under this intense power, the demon's figure quickly disintegrated until not even a speck of hair remained.

Lan Yingying swallowed nervously at Yuan's destructive power, as it was unlike anything she had experienced before.

After killing the demon, a notification appeared in front of Yuan.

[Congratulations! You have slain a Demon, obtaining the title 'Demon Slayer'!]

Meanwhile, outside the Mystic Realm, an announcement appeared in the skies for the players to see.

[Player Yuan has become the world's first player to have killed a Demon!]

The players wondered what a demon was and how they are different from magical beasts.

"Feng Feng, what's a Demon?" Meiuxiu asked her after seeing the notification.

"Huh? A fiend? Why are you suddenly asking about fiends? They are incredibly evil and powerful beings that used to rule the cultivation world." Feng Yuxiang looked at her with raised eyebrows.

Demons are also known as fiends, and they used to run rampant in the cultivation world.

"Well... Yuan just killed a demon inside the Mystic Realm, so I'm asking," Meixiu revealed this to them.

"What?! He killed a demon?! How is that possible?!" Feng Yuxiang's eyes nearly popped out of their sockets after hearing Meixiu's words.

"Demons have heaven-defying regenerative abilities and cannot be killed by normal means! Even the weakest demons are as strong as a peak Spirit Master! I know the Young Master is incredibly talented, but he doesn't have what it takes to kill a demon— at least he shouldn't!"

"W-Wait a second... There are demons in the Mystic Realm? How come no participants have encountered one until today? And I thought they went extinct after the Demon Sealing Clan purged them from the cultivation world..." Long Yijun mumbled in a dazed voice.

"The Mystic Realm is an ancient treasure so it's not impossible that there might be some demons inside. However, to actually run into one and even kill it... Disciple Yuan is an entirely different type of existence..." Elder Xuan said.

"I still can't believe it... How did the Young Master kill the demon? One must either know demon sealing techniques or have special spiritual energy that has divine attributes. However, I know for sure that the Young Master's spiritual energy doesn't have any divine attributes because I didn't sense it in his blood." Feng Yuxiang said, as she'd tasted his blood before.

"Then it could only be the demon sealing techniques..."

However, Xiao Hua shook her head and said, "Xiao Hua has been with Brother Yuan even before he was a cultivator and she doesn't recall Brother Yuan learning any techniques that allow him to seal demons..."

Because she'd been separated from Yuan in the Myriad of Techniques, Xiao Hua wasn't aware that Yuan had learned the Demon Sealing Strike.

"No matter how the Young Master killed that demon, I'm relieved to hear that he's safe despite encountering a demon. I still remember my first encounter with a demon in the upper heavens. It was a terrifying experience, to say the least..." Feng Yuxiang sighed.

"Eh? Madam Feng... You came from the upper heavens? And demons still exist in the upper heavens?" Elder Xuan looked at her with a surprised expression.

"Unfortunately, they still exist. They're just not as active and always in hiding... And yes, I came from the upper heavens. Due to circumstances, I am now here..." Feng Yuxiang sighed.

"I-I see..." Elder Xuan nodded.

Meanwhile, inside the Mystic Realm, at a place isolated from the rest of the world, a red-skinned figure lifted its head to look at the cloudy sky with a narrowed gaze as it sat on a red throne.

"That fool perished... Did he get too full of himself and went too deep into that man's Sword Aura? Even though I specifically warned him to not get ahead of himself." This demon mumbled, yet it expressed no sorrow after knowing that a fellow demon had just died.

Chapter 324 - Transformation

"Demon Lord, what should we do now that there's one less demon?"
Another demon suddenly asked after sensing the death of the demon Yuan had slain.

"Change? Nothing will change, except that we'll have more blood now to consume that he's gone. Perhaps we'll even be able to attack those annoying things a few days earlier now." The Demon Lord spoke as it turned to look at the other 3 demons.

"There used to be hundreds, thousands of us. However, that fucking human with the Sword Aura slaughtered us as though we're insects, and in just the span of a few years, our numbers have reduced to a mere dozen..."

Unlike humans and magical beasts that have to increase their lifespan through cultivation, demons have a near-infinite lifespan at birth, meaning they're immortal regardless of their cultivation base.

The Demon Lord's gaze turned to look at the small pool of blood in the center of these three demons and continued, "That Lan Family wanted to completely wipe us out, so they continued to attack us even after that human long disappeared. Although they'd manage to kill ten of us throughout the years, we also managed to kill two of them. Now, there's only four of us and three of them."

"In this world, they are the only beings that can threaten our existence. Once we get rid of them, we can finally rule the Mystic Realm. We're going to enslave the humans and drink their blood every day."

"If not for that damn human and his Sword Aura, we wouldn't be in this pitiful situation and be soaking in the humans' blood already! That bastard

even covered every city in this world with his Sword Aura, preventing us from gaining strength by eating humans!" Another demon expressed his frustration for the Lord.

The Demon Lord stood up a moment later and approached the pool of blood and shoved its hand inside before pulling it back out and using its hands as a cup, it drank a mouthful of the blood.

"No matter how many times I drink their blood, it's always a marvelous feeling. Once we gain enough resistance to the Sword Aura, we'll kill the rest of the Lan Family and consume their blood before dealing with the humans in the cities. Eventually, we'll find a way to control the Mystic Realm and open this world back up, allowing us to go outside, where there'll be even more humans for us to play with!"

While the demons prepared their attack, Yuan went to pick up something that was left behind by the demon after he killed it.

"What's this?" Yuan showed the red crystal to Lan Yingying.

"That's a Demon Core, somewhat similar to monster cores, but they contain much more spiritual energy. However, they also contain a lot more impurities and can even make a human go mad if not handled properly." Lan Yingying explained to him with a somewhat weird expression on her face right now.

"Similar to monster cores...?" Yuan looked at the demon core with a pondering look on his face, wondering whether he should try to eat this thing or not, as it gave him an ominous feeling, almost like it was taboo to consume them.

"B-By the way..."

Lan Yingying suddenly spoke, looking quite fidgety.

"Do you think I can buy that demon core off you?" she asked him.

"Eh? You want this as well? What do you plan on doing with so many monster corpses and this demon core?" Yuan couldn't help but ask her.

"I know it may seem selfish of me, but I really need these things, especially since the demons will be attacking us soon. I must power myself up as much as possible so that I could assist my grandparents when they decide to attack. You saw how powerless I was just now against that demon. At this rate, I'll only be a burden..." Lan Yingying sighed.

After pondering for a moment, Yuan nodded his head and extended his hand, offering the demon core to her.

"Here. I don't need any money. Instead, can you tell me more about your situation? I want to see if I'll be able to help you out." Yuan said to her.

"A-Are you sure?" Lan Yingying looked at him with a dazed look on her face. "What about your friends? Don't you need to regroup with them?"

"I do, but I cannot just leave you alone after learning about the demons."

Furthermore, if he helps her situation and slays the demons, the Dragon Essence Temple will still earn points. After all, there was no rule that said one couldn't act independently and earn points this way.

'I still don't know where the other two are, anyway.' Yuan thought to himself.

After a moment of silence, Lan Yingying accepted the demon core before nodding her head, "Okay. I'll tell you about myself and our situation."

After taking a deep breath, she continued, "As you can probably tell from my white hair and eye color, I am different from your average human. In fact, I am not really a human..."

"Eh? You're not human? Then what are you?" Yuan's eyes widened with surprise.

"I'll show you my real form, but before I do, I must warn you that I'm a little big..."

After taking another deep breath, Lan Yingying's body slowly began to transform, and her body grew longer and rounder, resembling that of a serpent.

In just moments, the beautiful Lan Yingying had turned into a massive and long snake with pretty white scales, transforming the lower half of her body first before transforming the rest of her body, becoming a full-fledged snake that was around 50 meters in length.

"This is my real form," Lan Yingying spoke in a nervous voice after her transformation, and she continued, "I am actually a Divine Beast, and our species are known as Divine Serpents. The reason I am collecting the corpses is simply because I plan on consuming them, as that's how we improve our cultivation."

"..."

Yuan was speechless, yet there was not even a hint of fear in his gaze. If anything, he was filled with awe at this moment.

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Chapter 325 - Riding Lan Yingying

"Wow... You're actually a big snake? This is my first time seeing something like this. How cool!" Yuan said to her in an excited voice after a moment of silence.

"C-Cool? Me?" Lan Yingying was taken by surprise after hearing such words. This is also her first time encountering a human who doesn't show even the slightest feeling of fear even after seeing her true form.

Although there have been humans who didn't express fear towards her true form before, she knew they were nervous and fearful of her inwardly, and they were just too scared of expressing it, fearing that it might anger her and be the end of their lives.

"Do you think I can touch your body?" Yuan suddenly asked her.

"Eh? S-Sure..." Lan Yingying nodded after a brief moment of hesitation.

Hearing her approval, Yuan immediately approached her and caressed her beautiful white scales with his hand.

"Wow... It's so smooth..." Yuan mumbled after feeling its unique texture that was unlike anything he's touched before.

"..."

Lan Yingying felt a little bit embarrassed at this moment even though she didn't feel any shame when she was half-naked in front of Yuan before, as this is her first time letting a human being touch her divine scales.

"How does your transformation work? I know a phoenix who is also in human form, but her situation is a little bit unique." Yuan then asked her.

"Y-You know a phoenix?" Lan Yingying's body shuddered after learning this.

"Yes. We're good friends," he said.

"Well... All magical beasts have the ability to transform into humans after they reach a certain cultivation level, but this requirement differs with each species as some magical beasts can transform much earlier than others. However, Divine Beasts such as myself usually require a much higher cultivation base to transform into a human since our bodies are somewhat unique."

"With that being said, my species is also unique in this sense since we can transform into humans as early as reaching Spirit Master." Lan Yingying explained to him.

"What about your human body? Are they any different compared to normal humans?"

Lan Yingying shook her head and said, "No, there aren't any differences as far as I'm aware. We have the same internal organs and reproductive systems as normal humans when we transform."

After a brief pause, she continued, "Actually, there is one thing that's different— our Dantian. Even if we can transform our bodies, we cannot transform our core Dantian or spiritual energy, and that's how people usually tell us— well, normal magical beasts— apart from real humans. Divine Beasts are different and can imitate human spiritual energy almost perfectly so most people can't tell the difference between Divine Beasts and humans."

"I see... How amazing... The cultivation world is truly a mythical place where anything is possible." Yuan expressed his awe for the cultivation world again.

Sometime later, Lan Yingying asked him, "What do you want to do now, Yuan? I have to return to my grandparents to warn them about the situation so I won't be able to accompany you any further."

"I'll come with you," Yuan said.

"Are you sure? This is a fight between demons and Divine Beasts... You will get hurt— even die." Lan Yingying warned him.

As much as she wanted Yuan to help them with his sealing techniques, she couldn't bear to see him die because of their situation.

"I'm sure. I can't just leave you alone, especially not after what that demon said." Yuan sighed, recalling how the demon talked about drinking her parents' blood.

After a moment of silence, Lan Yingying nodded and said, "Get on my back. I'll let you ride me. We'll travel faster this way, too."

"I can ride you?" Yuan's eyes flickered with excitement, as he has never imagined riding a massive snake like a mount before.

Lan Yingying nodded.

Seeing her approval, Yuan jumped on Lan Yingying's back.

"I'll move slowly at first so you can get used to it." Lan Yingying said as she began slithering her massive body across the ground gracefully.

"Oh?" Yuan was surprised when he could barely feel Lan Yingying's body moving despite her movements, almost like there was some sort of invisible force keeping him stable and safe.

It was so stable that he could probably take a nap without falling off.

Lan Yingying increased her movement speed every few minutes, and after some time, she was moving faster than flying swords.

"Are you okay, Yuan?" She asked him just in case.

"Yes! This is awesome!"

"We should return to my grandparents' home in a few hours." Lan Yingying said to him.

"Okay." Yuan nodded.

Meanwhile, in the real world, Meixiu sat before her laptop with a cup of cold water in her hand.

There was only a couple of hours left for the Frozen Jade Zither auction before it officially ends, and the 411 million had increased to a grand 525 million dollars.

[Yu Family has bid 526,100,000!]

[Anonymous has bid 526,200,000!]

[MusicGenius has bid 526,300,000!]

Meixiu watched as the price for the Frozen Jade Zither skyrocketed, albeit at smaller increments.

Although it may seem crazy that someone would be willing to spend so much money on a virtual item in a video game, when the world is dominated by video games with the majority of people in the world playing games actively, the abnormal slowly becomes the norm, especially with how hyped and popular Cultivation Online has been.

Furthermore, spending astronomical amounts of money on video games has long become the norm ever since the creation of the Legacy Families.

530 million... 540 million... 550 million...

The number grew closer and closer to 600 million, and the number of viewers on the website has returned to its peak numbers when the auction first started, as everyone there wanted to witness and be part of history when the most expensive in-game item is being sold.

When there were only 10 minutes left in the auction, the number stopped exactly at 600 million without any more bids.

As for the highest bidder, it was the Yu Family that had plenty of money to spare.

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Chapter 326 - End Of The Frozen Jade Zither Auction

"The Yu Family, huh. How amusing that they're paying so much money to Yuan after kicking him out of the family and robbing him of everything while being completely oblivious to the truth..." Meixiu could only imagine the shock on the Yu Family's face once they realize Player Yuan's true identity. Perhaps they might even puke blood once they learn the truth.

"If they had treated Yuan with even the slightest of care, perhaps the Yu Family wouldn't have needed to spend so much money on the Frozen Jade Zither," Meixiu mumbled to herself as the last ten minutes slowly approached zero.

Meanwhile, across all COPlayerAuctions' headquarters and working buildings around the world, all of its staff members were watching the auction with wide grins on their faces, looking like they were just minutes away from winning the lottery.

"Hahaha! Congratulations, Lee! You'll definitely be promoted after this auction that'll definitely make history! Hell, they might even move you to the main headquarters!" His fellow workers treated Lee differently after they realized that the treasure and auction were real, acting like they never doubted him in the first place.

"Don't forget about us when you move up the ladder, Lee!"

Although these people were praising and cheering for Lee's success out in the open and acted like they were happy for him, they were actually burning with envy inwardly, cursing the heavens for not sending the notification for the auction request to them instead of Lee.

"Thank you all. If I hadn't listened to my guts and ignored the auction request, we wouldn't be here right now." Lee said to them with the widest smile in the room on his face.

Not only will he receive recognition for his work, but he'll also receive a small portion of that 10% service fee, and even if it's just 10 percent of that 10 percent, he'd be earning at least 6 million dollars, which is far more than his total income after working for the company for over twenty years.

"Look! It increased by another million! Who is this MusicGenius?!" One of them asked.

"That's the pride of the Jiang Family, he's a musical genius who shook the world with his musical talents at 10 years old, and he has been playing for Royal Entertainment for the last 9 years."

"Royal Entertainment? Ah, they're the Yu Family's number one rival, who owns Jade Entertainment."

"So it's a battle between the two largest giants in the music industry, huh? I wonder who'll end up victorious since they both have enormous wealth."

The staff and hundreds of millions of people around the world watched as two families fought for the Frozen Jade Zither.

[Yu Family bids 603,000,000!]

[MusicGenius bids 605,000,000!]

[Yu Family bids 610,000,000!]

[MusicGenius bids 610,100,000!]

[Yu Family bids 610,200,000!]

The battle between the Yu Family and MusicGenius continued even a couple of minutes after the timer for the auction reached zero. Once the bid remains unmatched for 10 seconds, the winner will be decided!

When the auction reached 620,000,000, the viewers watched in anticipation as the final countdown started!

[00:10]

[00:09]

[00:08]

[00:07]

Once the countdown finally reached zero, a large announcement appeared in the middle of the website.

[Congratulations to the Yu Family for winning this bid!]

In the end, the Yu Family won the bid, but it'd cost them 620 million dollars.

However, while this may seem like a lot of money, it was only a drop in the bucket for them who owns one of the largest entertainment companies in the world with businesses and branches all over the world, earning them billions annually.

Once the auction ended, 620 million dollars were deducted from the Yu Family's account before being sent straight to Meixiu's account on the website with the service fees already deducted.

In the end, Meixiu received 558,000,000 dollars from the auction and an additional 20,000 dollars for her initial deposit that was doubled by Lee.

Meixiu wasted no time withdrawing the money, depositing it directly to the bank account that she shared with Yuan.

Normally, having such a massive amount of money suddenly deposited into one's bank account at once would alert the bank and trigger some sort of investigation, but luckily for Yuan and Meixiu, the bank account was created by Yu Rou, who was the daughter of the prestigious Yu Family, granting that bank account premium features such as absolute anonymity.

Meixiu went to look at the bank account to make sure the money had been deposited, and sure enough, there were 558,020,000 dollars inside.

Ding!

A notification from the COPlayerAuctions appeared a few minutes after the auction ended.

[Congratulations on the auction! The upper management would like to request an interview with you. They have promised that you'll receive full anonymity so you don't have to worry about your identities being leaked. What do you say?]

After reading the notification, Meixiu typed three words without any hesitation—

[No, thank you.]

[I understand. If you ever have something else that you'd like to sell, please don't hesitate to use COPlayerAuctions again! We'll even give you some sort of deal such as reducing the service fees! Once again, thank you for trusting and using our platform!]

The internet went crazy with everybody talking about the Frozen Jade Zither's auction, and many people believed it to be Player Yuan's treasure.

Meanwhile, inside the Mystic Realm, Yuan and Lan Yingying had just returned to the temple.

"There are too many trees here so we'll have to go on foot." Lan Yingying said to him before transforming back to her human form.

Her white hair and pink eyes also returned back to their original colors.

Sometime later, they arrived at the cabin.

"Grandfather! Grandmother!" Lan Yingying called out to them as they approached the cabin.

"Hm? You're back with the young man already? Did you decide to change your mind and impregnate our granddaughter, after all?" The grandparents were pleasantly surprised to see Yuan return with Lan Yingying so quickly.

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Chapter 327 - Preparing For The Demons Invasion

Chapter 327 - Preparing For The Demons' Invasion

"Grandfather, this isn't the time to joke. We have an emergency." Lan Yingying said to him as she retrieved the demon core and showed it to him.

"Hmm? What's that?" Grandpa Lan didn't immediately recognize the demon core since it has been many years since he last saw one.

However, when he finally realized what he was looking at, his eyes widened with surprise, and his playful expression turned solemn.

"Where did you get that demon core?" He asked her in a serious voice, and he continued, "Let's talk inside."

A few moments later, they returned to the table.

Once all four of them were fully seated, Lan Yingying recalled their encounter with the demon and how Yuan defeated it.

"We were attacked by a demon on our way to the city," she started off with this shocking information.

"What?! Impossible! The Lord's Sword Aura should have prevented them from getting so close to the city!" Grandma Lan said.

"Yes... But they absorbed my parents' blood, granting them resistance to the Sword Aura." Lan Yingying sighed.

"They what?! These damn demons!" Grandpa Lan slammed the desk in a small fit of rage.

After a moment of awkward silence, Grandma Lan spoke, "Then what happened to that demon? Surely, you didn't kill it, since we know you can't kill demons yet..."

Lan Yingying nodded and said, "The demon was killed, but I was not the one who killed it."

She then turned to look at Yuan and continued, "Yuan was the one who killed it."

"Y-You?"

The grandparents turned to look at Yuan with disbelief written all over their faces. How could a human that's only a Spirit Warrior kill a demon? Judging by the energy coming from the demon core, that demon should've been no weaker than a peak Spirit Master.

A Spirit Warrior defeating a peak Spirit Master? In what world would this make any sense?

"H-How on earth did you kill the demon?" They asked him a moment later, still with a dazed look on their faces.

"I used a sealing technique on the demon before finishing it off," Yuan responded in a casual manner, acting like it was only an ordinary magical beast that he'd slain.

"Sealing technique? Are you perhaps from the Demon Sealing Clan in the outside world? They were always there to help whenever a demon was involved." Grandpa Lan asked him.

Yuan shook his head, "No, I am not associated with the Demon Sealing Clan. I learned the sealing technique by chance."

"B-By chance, you say?" The grandparents looked at each other.

Demon sealing techniques are incredibly rare because the Demon Sealing Clan seized most of the techniques during the ancient times and forbade

people from sharing the technique with strangers, as it was the pride of their family and what made them unique in the cultivation world.

Therefore, learning such a technique 'by chance' was very unlikely.

"Anyways, let me continue. The demon Yuan slew said that the rest of the demons intend on raiding the Divine Forest in two weeks. What should we do?" Lan Yingying asked them.

"Two weeks, huh?" They mumbled before turning quiet to ponder.

After a long moment of silence, Grandpa Lan looked at Yuan before asking him, "What do you plan on doing, young man?"

"I'd like to help you with whatever I can," he quickly responded.

"I see... We greatly appreciate it, and your demon sealing technique will definitely help our situation a lot, but are you sure? It's going to be very dangerous fighting against the demons."

"Since you already killed one, there should be four demons left, including the Demon Lord, who is the most powerful of them all. And judging from the demon core you got, that demon was probably the weakest of the bunch."

"If you stay here with us, we cannot guarantee your safety."

Yuan nodded and said, "There's still two weeks before they attack, right? That's plenty of time for me to increase my strength."

"Uhh... I guess..."

In their eyes, two weeks was no different than two days, and not many improvements can be made in such a short time even if he was a peak genius. If Yuan was given two years, perhaps he might be able to assist their fight with the Demon Lord, but at his current level, he wouldn't even be able to get in range to attack the Demon Lord without dying.

"I understand. If you need anything at all, just let us know." Grandpa Lan said to him.

Hearing such words, Yuan didn't hesitate to ask, "Then do you have any monster cores?"

"Monster cores? No, we don't. However, we can hunt some magical beasts and get you some." Grandpa Lan said.

"How many do you need? Most magical beasts around this area are above Spirit Master."

"I want as many as possible if you don't mind," Yuan said without hesitation.

"I understand. I'll go hunt some magical beasts after this."

"Thank you for the trouble," Yuan said to him.

"Hahaha... Don't mind it. No amount of monster cores will be able to match a demon core for us."

Sometime later, Yuan asked them, "By the way, I have been wondering... Since Miss Lan is a Divine Beast, does this mean both of you are also Divine Beasts?"

"Oh? Yingying told you about it?"

Yuan nodded.

"That's right. I am also a Divine Beast. However, Grandma Lan here is not a Divine Beast."

"My real form is a Jade Serpent—I am just an ordinary magical beast." Grandma Lan said.

"When a Divine Beast mates with an ordinary magical beast, the baby will always be a Divine Beast, but we can only have one child in our lifetime." Grandpa Lan explained to him.

"I see..." Yuan mumbled.

"Anyways, if the demons want to attack us, we'll be fully prepared for them." Grandpa Lan said.

"However, it won't be easy defeating four demons when there are only two of us who can actually kill the demons— me and you, young man."

"I'm going to hunt some magical beasts right now and see if I can get you some monster cores. In the meantime, you can stay here with the other two. Of course, if you want to be more productive, you can always mate with Yingying." Grandpa Lan said with a smile on his face before leaving the cabin.

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Chapter 328 - Consuming Magical Beasts

Once Grandpa Lan left the cabin, the atmosphere immediately turned silent.

"Young man, would you like some tea?" Grandma Lan suddenly asked him.

"I do," he quickly nodded.

"Okay, I'll go prepare some for you right now."

Lan Yingying then said, "I'm going to increase my cultivation."

"Oh? Do you cultivate normally like humans or do you do something else to improve your cultivation?" Yuan asked her.

"I can cultivate normally, but that's not the most effective method for us—at least my bloodline. In order to increase my cultivation base quickly, I must consume other magical beasts."

Yuan's eyes flickered with interest and excitement after hearing her words, and he asked, "Does this mean you can also eat monster cores?"

Lan Yingying nodded, "We can eat them, but monster cores take very long for us to fully absorb, and the amount of spiritual energy we obtain from monster cores cannot compare to the magical beasts' body itself. And it sometimes gives us stomachaches, so I tend to avoid eating them."

"Wow..." Yuan mumbled.

Even though her method of eating monster cores differs from his own method, it was still quite fascinating to find someone else who can 'eat'

monster cores.

"Do you think I can watch you?" Yuan suddenly asked her.

"Y-You want to watch me consume magical beasts?" Lan Yingying looked at him with wide eyes.

"Yes." Yuan nodded, his gaze filled with curiosity.

"I-I guess..." Lan Yingying nodded after feeling slight hesitation.

"Follow me outside."

Once they were outside, Lan Yingying retrieved all of the magical beast corpses that they'd collected during their journey, piling them up like a small mountain.

Lan Yingying glanced at Yuan for a brief second before transforming into her beast form.

She then grabbed one of the magical beasts' corpses with her tail and lifted it in the air, directly above her head.

After taking a deep breath, Lan Yingying opened her large mouth before releasing her tail, dropping the magical beast's corpse into her mouth and swallowing it whole.

Yuan watched in fascination. He never thought magical beasts could cultivate in such a manner.

"Haaaa..."

Lan Yingying released a satisfied noise after swallowing the magical beast, and white flames could be seen blowing out of her mouth and nose when she breathed.

After eating her first magical beast, Lan Yingying picked up the second one and proceeded to consume that one in a single bite as well.

In just a few moments, Lan Yingying cleaned up the mountain of magical beasts, and she was so absorbed in eating that she'd forgotten about Yuan watching her.

"Ah, that was delicious~!" Lan Yingying spoke with a satisfied voice.

"Amazing... Where does all of that go? Even if your body is big, it's weird seeing how you consume a mountain of magical beasts and still look completely normal." Yuan asked her.

If he ate a lot of food, his stomach would bloat a little.

"Oh... I don't really 'consume' them. I burn them with Sacred Fire, converting them to spiritual energy inside my body and increasing my cultivation that way. This way, I won't feel full no matter how many magical beasts I consume."

"I see..." Yuan nodded.

Sometime later, Lan Yingying returned to her human form before going back inside the cabin with Yuan to drink tea Grandma Lan made.

"Can you tell me more about the outside world?" Lan Yingying suddenly asked him.

"The outside? What do you want to know?"

"I don't know. Anything you know."

Yuan pondered for a moment before nodding, "Okay, I don't know much, but I'll tell you everything I have experienced outside."

Thus, Yuan began telling her of his journey ever since he became a cultivator.

Of course, the story didn't last long since Yuan hadn't been a cultivator for long.

"I see... The outside world seems like a wonderful place. In this world, we cannot wander too much or leave the Lord's Sword Aura or the demons will be able to kill us." Lan Yingying sighed.

After tea, Grandma Lan took Yuan upstairs to the rooms and said to him, "Since we don't expect guests, we don't have any spare rooms. Therefore, how about you share a room with Yingying? Her bed is big enough to fit two people comfortably, too!"

The smile on her face grew wider and wider the more she spoke.

"It's okay, I don't need a room," Yuan said, dumbfounding Grandma Lan.

"Then where will you sleep?" She asked.

"I will be cultivating so it doesn't matter if I have a room or not," he responded.

"I-Is that so..." Grandma mumbled, feeling that getting this young man to mate with their granddaughter might be harder than defeating even the Demon Lord.

Yuan logged off sometime later as it was getting late.

"Yuan, the auction ended," Meixiu said to him during dinner.

"Really? How much did it sell for?"

"The Frozen Jade Zither sold for 620 million dollars, and we got 558,020,000 dollars after the service fees."

"Now we can pay for the rent of this place even though Yu Rou's friend is willing to lend it to us for free," Yuan said.

Meixiu raised her eyebrows. This is the first thing he thinks about after obtaining so much money? Paying for rent? If he wanted, he could even buy this entire building and still have plenty left.

"Ah, can you tell Xiao Hua and the others that I most likely won't be able to regroup with the other two disciples anytime soon." Yuan suddenly said.

"Huh? Why? Did something happen?"

"Yes, and it's not something I can ignore," Yuan said, and he proceeded to explain the Lan Family's situation to Meixiu.

"Demons, huh? I understand. I'll let them know when I log on tomorrow."

"Thank you," Yuan said.

"Oh, right. One more thing, Meixiu. If you need to buy something, just use the money we got from the auction. You don't need to ask me for permission."

"Are you sure? It's your money..." She said.

"What am I going to do with so much money? If we ever run out, I can just sell some more items." Yuan said.

"I understand. Thank you, Yuan."

Meixiu went to sleep shortly after cleaning up and Yuan spent the night cultivating in the real world.

Chapter 329 - Heaven Refining Physique

The following morning, Meixiu logged into the game after feeding Yuan breakfast, and she relayed to them Yuan's situation.

"As expected of the Young Master... Willingly helping these people even though they're up against demons..." Fang Yuxiang sighed with a look of admiration on her face.

Even if she was in her phoenix form and with all of her powers, she wouldn't dare to fight demons unless it was absolutely necessary.

"Tell Brother Yuan to not push himself too hard when you get the chance," Xiao Hua said to Meixiu.

"I understand."

Meanwhile, inside the Mystic Realm, Yuan went to visit the faceless statue again.

"Just who are you...?" He mumbled as he stared at the statue with a dazed look on his face.

Sometime later, Lan Yingying approached him and said, "Yuan, my grandfather has returned."

"Hm? Already? That was fast."

The two of them returned to the cabin a few minutes later.

"Hey, young man, I have returned." Grandpa Lan said to Yuan as he extended his hand with a leather pouch in his grasp.

"I have hunted every magical beast in the Divine Forest. Although there weren't many magical beasts in the first place, I have managed to obtain a couple of monster cores for you."

"Thank you very much!" Yuan accepted the leather pouch with a wide smile on his face.

"Yingying, I saved their corpses for you." Grandpa Lan then handed a spatial ring to her.

"Thank you, grandfather."

"Don't mention it. The two of us have reached our limits so it won't do us any good. However, this is also the same for those demons. Therefore, we should focus on the two of you, who can still grow." Grandpa Lan said to them.

"I'm going to consume them in a bit." Lan Yingying said.

"What about you, young man? There may not be many monster cores inside, but you won't be able to absorb all of them in two weeks. Go ahead — take a look inside."

Yuan nodded and opened the storage pouch, and 3 monster cores fell onto his palms.

"Two Spirit Master monster cores and one at the Spirit Grandmaster level." Grandpa Lan said.

"Wow, this is much better than I'd expected! Once again, thanks!"

"Hahaha... You can thank me by mating with Yingying..." Grandpa Lan said, not giving up on this matter just yet.

Sometime later, Lan Yingying went outside so that she could consume the magical beasts her grandfather brought back.

And to Yuan's surprise, over three hundred magical beasts' corpses piled up in front of the cabin, surpassing the previous mountain by at least three folds.

It took over three hundred magical beasts to obtain 3 monster cores? Yuan dreaded how many he'd need to kill in order to obtain one in the future as he grows stronger since it'll only get harder to obtain them.

While Lan Yingying consumed the magical beasts, Yuan tilted his mask and prepared to swallow the monster cores.

Grandpa Lan expressed great shock after seeing what he was trying to do, and he quickly exclaimed, "What do you think you're doing?! Don't tell me you got the urge to eat monster cores after witnessing Yingying eat the magical beasts, right?! You'll die!"

"Eh?" Lan Yingying stopped eating to see what the commotion was about.

"Young man, humans cannot consume monster cores. Even magical beasts cannot do it. Yingying is a little bit special because of her unique bloodline as a Divine Beast, and even she gets stomachaches from swallowing them." Grandma Lan shook her head.

"It's okay," said Yuan in a calm voice, and he continued, "I also have a special physique, and it allows me to consume monster cores."

Lan Yingying and her grandparents' jaw dropped from shock after hearing his words. Can he really eat monster cores? What kind of heaven-defying physique does he have?

"Here, let me show you..."

Yuan said as he tossed one of the Spirit Master monster cores into his mouth, swallowing the tiny amount of sweet liquid left behind afterward.

[Heaven Refining Physique activated]

[??? Qi has been refined from the Earth Dragon's monster core]

[You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough]

[You have reached Sixth Spirit Warrior]

[+3,500 Stats]

[You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough]

[You have reached Seventh Level Spirit Warrior]

[+4,000 Stats]

[You have reached Eight Level Spirit Warrior]

[+4,500 Stats]

[You have reached Ninth Level Spirit Warrior]

[+5,000 Stats]

[You have reached First Level Spirit Master]

[+10,000 Stats]

[You have reached Second Level Spirit Master]

[+11,000 Stats]

"Whooo..." Yuan released a deep breath after consuming the monster core.

"See? I am perfectly fine," he said to them afterward.

However, there was no response from the grandparents or Lan Yingying, as they all stared at him with a gawking expression on their faces.

They always thought Yuan to be a human being, but after witnessing him consume monster cores and breakthrough multiple realms as easy as breathing, they began to doubt whether he was really human or not. Hell,

they wouldn't doubt it even if Yuan suddenly revealed to them that he was a Divine Beast this entire time.

"Y-Young man... If you don't mind me asking, what kind of physique do you have?" Grandpa Lan asked him in a trembling voice.

Yuan nodded and said, "Heaven Refining Physique."

He didn't mind telling them since he trusted them.

"H-Heaven Refining Physique?! That legendary physique?!" Grandpa Lan unconsciously took a few steps back from shock.

"You know of my physique?" Yuan asked, his interest piqued.

After taking a deep breath, Grandpa Lan nodded and said, "The Heaven Refining Physique is one of the most mythical physiques to ever exist, and if I remember correctly, the founder of the Demon Sealing Clan had this physique..."

"The founder?" Yuan raised his eyebrows. "How long ago are we talking about?"

"Many millions of years ago, I guess..." Grandpa Lan said, and he continued, "The founder of the Demon Sealing Clan was also rumored to eat demon cores, but nobody has ever confirmed it..."

Chapter 330 - Bane Of Demons

"What else do you know about the founder of the Demon Sealing Clan?" Yuan asked him, his interest piqued. Perhaps he might learn something new about his physique.

"Not much, honestly. He was a powerful man— one of the most powerful entities during his time, and he founded the Demon Sealing Clan to slay demons."

"Nobody knows his background or his motives for founding the clan, but all of the humans and even magical beasts admired him like a god. As for the demons, well, they'd run just from the mention of his name."

"What was his name?" Yuan asked.

"Unfortunately, his name has been lost to the passage of time, so nobody really knows. However, we know his nickname— Bane of Demons, Divine Paragon!"

"Divine Paragon? What a cool nickname..." Yuan mumbled, thinking how nice it would be if he also had a nickname.

Sometime later, Yuan proceeded to consume the other two monster cores.

[Heaven Refining Physique activated]

[??? Qi has been refined from the Forest Mantis's monster core]

[You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough]

[You have reached Third Level Spirit Master]

[+12,000]

[You have reached Fourth Level Spirit Master]

[+13,000]

"Heavens... It took you two monster cores to increase your cultivation base by almost an entire realm... Does your Heaven Refining Physique have a limit?" Grandpa Lan mumbled in a dazed voice.

"A limit, huh? I have never reached this so-called limit yet, so I can't really tell you." Yuan said.

"Is that so... But don't push yourself too hard." Grandpa Lan said.

"I won't," Yuan said.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan popped the last monster core into his mouth, which contained the power of a Spirit Grandmaster that is considered to be the peak of the Lower Heavens.

WHOOSH!

Yuan could feel his body gushing with spiritual energy after consuming the monster core, feeling as though many years of unused energy suddenly surge forward.

[Heaven Refining Physique]

[??? Qi has been absorbed from the Blood Ripper]

[You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough]

[You have reached Fifth Level Spirit Master]

[+14,000]

[You have reached Sixth Level Spirit Master]

[+15,000]

[You have reached Seventh Level Spirit Master]

[+16,000]

[You have reached Eighth Level Spirit Master]

[+17,000]

[You have reached Ninth Level Spirit Master]

[+18,000]

Yuan's cultivation base stopped at the ninth level.

"I didn't reach Spirit Grandmaster, but I can somehow feel it..." Yuan mumbled, feeling as though his body had grown larger from the sheer amount of power that resided within his body at this moment.

"My lord... Are you okay, young man? Do you feel any different right now? Any pain?" Grandpa Lan asked him.

Normally, one wouldn't be able to increase their cultivation base so quickly, skipping so many levels at once. If they did, it was most likely with the help of some priceless treasure, and it would only be one or two levels, not an entire realm and some more. However, even then, their body will feel uncomfortable, even pain from the overwhelming amount of spiritual energy suddenly going inside their body.

"I feel perfectly fine— actually, I feel a little full, almost like I just ate a feast, but it's spiritual energy instead of food..." Yuan said.

"You shouldn't keep so much energy inside your body for too long or it might actually harm your body. Go and release it by training your techniques." Grandpa Lan said to Yuan, and he pointed in a certain direction before continuing, "There's a training area not far from here."

"Okay, I'll go now. Thank you!" Yuan immediately began running to the training area, and compared to before, his speed almost tripped.

In just a few minutes, he arrived at this spacious area that had large boulders placed everywhere with the largest boulder as large as a ten-story building.

And without further ado, Yuan retrieved the Empyrean Overlord and began his rampage on these boulders.

[Bloody Sword Strike!]

Yuan released as much spiritual energy as he could with the technique.

Whoosh!

A strong gust of wind appeared as the Empyrean Overlord cleaved the large boulders cleanly in half, almost like a sharp knife against a piece of paper.

[Heaven Splitting Sword Strike!]

Yuan used his strongest attack on the ten-story building after cleaving a few large boulders.

The entire ground shook as a massive beam of spiritual energy released from the Empyrean Overlord and flew towards the building.

BOOM!

The entire boulder disintegrated until nothing was left in an instant, almost like Yuan had used a flamethrower on a ball of cotton.

However, the attack didn't stop at the boulder and continued flying into the distance— directly at the mountain not far away.

BOOM!

The ground shook again as the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike created a large hole in this mountain.

Meanwhile, back at the cabin, Grandpa Lan held a profound expression on his face as he stared at the hole that had suddenly appeared in this mountain at the horizon.

"Yingying, what do you think of this human?" He suddenly asked her, who was still stuffing her mouth with magical beasts.

"Yuan?" she stopped eating and asked.

"If... If you can leave this world, would you be willing to follow him, is what I'm trying to ask." Grandpa Lan spoke with a solemn look on his face.

"I-I can leave this world? Really?!"

"I won't guarantee you anything, but if you bring this human to the Mystic Pagoda, he might be able to bring you outside—it's a strong feeling I am getting right now, and my intuition is rarely wrong."

"But the demons will be attacking us soon! And he only has a month in this place!" Lan Yingying said.

"I know, which is why instead of being sitting ducks and waiting for them to prepare for the invasion, we should strike them first when they least expect it." Grandpa Lan suddenly suggested, shocking Lan Yingying.

"Once you consume all of the magical beasts and the young man gets used to his newfound strength, we'll attack."

Chapter 331 - Learning To Fly

After spending almost the entire day exhausting himself, Yuan returned to the cabin.

"Welcome back, young man. How do you feel?" Grandpa Lan said to him.

"I feel even better than before despite having less energy," Yuan said, feeling as though he'd released all of his pent-up frustration by destroying countless boulders.

"Good. Then let me tell you our plans." Grandpa Lan said, and he continued, "Instead of waiting for the demons to invade us, we're going to invade them before they're fully prepared, and we're going to do it in three days. Do you think you'll be ready by then?"

"Three days, huh? I think I will be ready." Yuan nodded.

"Great, then if you need anything until then, don't hesitate to let us know."

Sometime later, Yuan logged off for dinner.

After dinner, Yuan cultivated until the morning, reaching 6th level Spirit Warrior.

When he returned to the game, Yuan took a seat outside the cabin and began practicing his Qi Manifestation.

"This is definitely much easier now that I'm at the ninth level Spirit Master..." Yuan mumbled to himself as he manifested the spiritual inside of his body without any effort at all.

After practicing for a couple of hours, a notification appeared before him.

[You have learned Qi Manifestation]

[Qi Manifestation]

[Rank: Earth]

[Description: Allows you to release your spiritual energy outside the body and use it as a weapon.]

"Let's try this..." Yuan stood up and turned to look at a tree that was a couple of meters from him.

After taking a deep breath, he imagined his spiritual energy leaving his body and forming a fist, aiming it directly at the tree.

Boom!

Yuan's spiritual energy left his body and struck the tree a split second later, knocking the tree down.

"Wow, what a powerful technique... But how will this help me fly?"

After pondering for a moment, he went inside the cabin to find Grandpa Lan.

"Grandpa Lan, you can fly, right? Can you teach me how to fly using Qi Manifestation? I just learned it."

"You learned Qi Manifestation already? As expected of a genius..."
Grandpa Lan looked at him with slightly wide eyes, but compared to his other talents, this wasn't shocking at all.

"If you know Qi Manifestation, then you also know Qi Manipulation. Try to manipulate the spiritual energy around you and control it. Once you control it, you can alter the gravity around you, allowing you to levitate. Practice enough and you'll be able to fly."

"I understand. Thank you for the advice."

Yuan went back outside to practice flying.

Once outside, he stood there silently without moving a muscle for many minutes, almost like he'd turned into a statue.

He used Qi Manifestation and tried to manipulate the spiritual energy around him.

Once he got used to the feeling, he imagined the spiritual energy lifting his body into the air, and after many minutes of practice, he'd managed to levitate himself a couple of inches off the ground.

"What a fast learner." Grandpa Lan mumbled to himself as he watched Yuan practice from inside the cabin with his Divine Sense.

After practicing for a couple more hours, Yuan could eventually soar in the sky, albeit a little bit slow.

[You have learned Fly]

[Fly]

[Rank: Earth]

[Description: Allows you to fly in the sky. The faster you fly, the more Qi you consume.]

"Although flying is fun, I think I still like flying with a sword."

With that in mind, Yuan retrieved the Empyrean Overlord and made it levitate in the air with Qi Manifestation.

Once he got used to controlling the sword in the air, he jumped on the sword and began surfing the air for the first time without Xiao Hua's assistance.

"Hahaha! This is great!"

Yuan proceeded to fly around the Divine Forest for the next few hours until he was almost out of spiritual energy and covered in sweat.

"I can fly around perfectly right now, but I wonder what will happen once I leave the Mystic Realm and lose my current cultivation base. Will I still be able to fly around since I have already learned the skills? And how much of my current cultivation will be transferred outside?" Yuan wondered to himself as he returned to the cabin.

"Welcome back, young man." Grandpa Lan said to him when he returned.

And when he noticed Yuan's sweaty appearance, he said, "There's a small waterfall not far from here. Go clean yourself there. Do you need directions?"

Yuan shook his head and said, "I saw that during my training so I know where to go. Thank you!"

He left the cabin again shortly after and flew to this waterfall that was a couple of miles away.

A few minutes after Yuan left, Grandpa Lan called for Lan Yingying.

"What's the matter, grandfather?" she asked him.

A large grin appeared on his face before he spoke, "The young man's cleaning himself at the waterfall. This is your chance to seduce him! Enter the water with him!"

"A-Are you serious, grandfather?" Lan Yingying looked at him with wide eyes.

"Does it look like I am joking?" Grandpa Lan responded with a serious expression.

"Old fart, don't force Yingying if she doesn't want to do it."

"Nonsense! She shares the same bloodline as me! I can tell if she likes someone or not! Tell me, Yingying— do you not like that young man? Even

if you don't, it's your duty to continue our bloodline!" Grandpa Lan said to her.

After a moment of silence, Lan Yingying nodded with a solemn expression, "I understand. I'll do my best."

Meanwhile, at the waterfall that has fresh and clean water, Yuan removed his clothes and quickly rinsed them in the waterfall before hanging them on a tree nearby.

After hanging the wet clothes, he went to test the waters before jumping right inside. This is his first time washing himself at a river, and there was even a waterfall right behind him.

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Chapter 332 - A Thousand Years

After hanging his clothes on a nearby tree to let them dry, Yuan entered the shallow river that barely reached his shoulders, rinsing the dried sweat off his body.

"Wow, this feels amazing!"

Maybe it was because of his body as a cultivator but the water didn't feel cold at all. It felt refreshing, resembling the feelings he'd get after a breakthrough.

After submerging himself in the water for a couple of minutes, Yuan turned to look at the waterfall and wondered what it would feel like to go under it, treating it like a shower.

"I'm a cultivator, so it should be fine, right?" Yuan mumbled to himself, a little bit worried that the waterfall might crush him to death if he went into it.

However, he won't know unless he tried it, so he approached the waterfall with care.

Once he was directly before the waterfall, Yuan stuck a finger inside the waterfall to test the pressure.

"It's not that bad..."

When he realized that he could withstand the pressure, he proceeded to insert his hand deeper into the waterfall.

"It feels very light— much lighter than it appears. Is it because of my body?"

After feeling comfortable and confident that his body could handle the waterfall, he took a few steps forward, entering the waterfall and allowing the water to pour down over his entire body.

"This feels great!"

It felt like he was being massaged by the waterfall.

Some minutes later, Yuan sensed a presence approaching the waterfall.

"Yuan, can I join you in the water?" Lan Yingying's figure could be seen in the distance and approaching his direction.

However, there was something different about her appearance, and Yuan's eyes widened with surprise when he saw her, who was completely naked at this moment.

She had a great figure with perfect portions from head to toe, pale skin that resembled snow, and on her chest were two luscious and round breasts that attracted Yuan's gaze, especially the small and elegant pink circles on her breasts. Her legs were slender and long, and between these beautiful legs was a single slit that made Yuan feel something he didn't understand.

"Miss Lan? You're also here to bathe?" Yuan asked her in a calm voice after his initial surprise.

If it was any other man in his situation, they might've gone crazy from the stimulation just at the sight of Lan Yingying's peerless body.

"Yes... I hope you don't mind," she said.

"Of course, not." Yuan quickly responded with an innocent smile on his face. "Please, join me. The water feels great and very refreshing."

Lan Yingying nodded and entered the water a moment later.

However, she didn't say anything else after entering the water.

'Grandfather told me to seduce him... But how do I do that?' Lan Yingying wondered inwardly, as nobody has ever taught her how to seduce humans before.

Furthermore, as someone who has lived in the Divine Forest for her entire life, she only knows what her family taught her as well as things she naturally learns as a Divine Beast, and none of this knowledge would help her seduce a human.

"You should come over here, " Yuan suddenly said to her, and he continued, "It feels even better under the waterfall."

Lan Yingying didn't say anything and merely nodded her head.

She slowly made her way to the waterfall, and a few moments later, she stood directly beside Yuan with the waterfall massaging their body.

After another moment of silence, Lan Yingying spoke, "Yuan, to tell you the truth, it was my grandfather who suggested I come here to seduce you. He really wants me to continue the family's legacy— to have a baby with you."

Lan Yingying felt that it was quite rude to keep such a thing hidden from him and didn't want to feel like she was lying to him, who was risking his own life to help their situation with the demons, so she told him the truth.

"Yuan, I understand why you don't want to have children, but remember, I am not human, so I am not giving birth to a human child. I am a Divine Beast; it's completely different. You can even consider it as having a pet or something."

Yuan turned to look at her with wide eyes, and after a moment of silence, he said, "Even if you say that... I don't know how to make babies. I was only taught how to play instruments and memorize songs."

"I-It's really simple!" Lan Yingying realized that she had a chance, so she quickly responded.

"I only need your blood and spiritual energy!" Lan Yingying then said.

"My blood and spiritual energy? I don't know how to make babies, but this doesn't sound right..." Yuan said with a confused look on his face.

Lan Yingying then said, "I don't know how humans make babies, but this is how we— Divine Beasts— conceive. Through blood and spiritual energy."

Yuan closed his eyes to ponder.

After a few minutes of silence, Yuan opened his eyes and said, "Okay, I'll help you."

"Really?!" Lan Yingying exclaimed.

Yuan nodded. "As you'd said, I am not really giving birth to a human child, and this is just a game..."

"T-Thank you! Let's begin immediately!"

Lan Yingying wasted no time transforming into her beast form.

"What should I do?" Yuan asked her.

"You just need to retrieve some of your blood and mix it with your spiritual energy."

"Okay, tell me when to stop."

Yuan took out the Starry Abyss and slit his palms before collecting his blood with Qi Manifestation.

"That's enough blood." Lan Yingying suddenly stopped him.

Yuan nodded and stopped draining his own blood.

"What should I do now?" Yuan asked as his own blood floated in front of him in the shape of a sphere.

"Mix it with your spiritual energy until I tell you to stop." Lan Yingying said.

Yuan followed her instructions and proceeded to mix his spiritual energy with the blood.

Slowly, his blood began glistening like there were stars living inside. A few more moments later, his blood began to solidify and clear up, almost like it was crystalizing, and it was also growing smaller in size.

"Okay, that's enough." Lan Yingying said to him once the crystalized blood was the size of his thumb.

"Here you go." Yuan handed his crystalized blood to Lan Yingying, who accepted it with her tail.

"Thank you very much for this, Yuan. I will never forget it." Lan Yingying said to him before throwing the crystal inside her mouth and eating it.

'T-This is?! What kind of blood is this?! I have never tasted anything this pure and delicious before!' Lan Yingying's eyes widened with shock a few seconds after swallowing Yuan's blood.

She then turned to look at Yuan with a weird glint in her eyes. If she wasn't a Divine Beast but an ordinary magical beast, perhaps she might've gone crazy and attacked Yuan purely because of his blood, especially when it's enhanced with his rich spiritual energy.

"Are you done?" Yuan asked her a moment later.

Lan Yingying snapped out of her daze and nodded her head.

"Yes, I should be able to conceive a child in the future."

"Do you know how long that will take?" Yuan then asked, his interest piqued.

Lan Yingying pondered for a moment before answering his question, "About a thousand years, give or take."

"Eh?" Yuan's eyes widened from surprise, and he proceeded to stare at her with a speechless look on his face.

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Chapter 333 - A Cup Of Blood

"A thousand years?! Does it really take that long? I cannot even fathom living that long!" Yuan exclaimed after learning how long it'll take for Lan Yingying to give birth to their child.

"Yes, it takes a really long time for Divine Beasts such as myself to convert the 'seed' that you gave me into a child." Lan Yingying said.

And she continued, "It also differs for each species. Some Divine Beasts may need a few hundred years while some may even need a few thousand years."

"If I recall correctly, Dragons and Phoenixes require the most time for their child— about ten thousand years."

"T-Ten thousand years!?" Yuan was completely speechless.

Sometime later, Lan Yingying returned to her human form.

"Once again, thank you for impregnating me." Lan Yingying lowered her head and bowed to him afterward.

The two of them proceeded to spend some more time in the river before getting out and returning to the cabin.

"How was the waterfall? I hope you had fun." Grandpa Lan welcomed them back with a massive grin on his face.

"Yes! It was really fun! It also felt really good! Thank you for recommending that place!" Yuan said to him.

"It felt good, huh?" The smile on Grandpa Lan's face widened even more.

"Grandfather, Yuan has agreed to impregnate me, and I have already absorbed his blood." Lan Yingying said to him.

"What?" Grandpa Lan turned to look at her with wide eyes filled with shock, as he didn't expect things to go so smoothly!

"Hahaha! This is great news! Welcome to the family, young man!" Grandma Lan laughed out loud after hearing this news.

And she continued, "We're going to have a feast tonight!"

However, Grandpa Lan continued to stand there with a dazed face. Even though he was the one who encouraged it the most, he truly didn't think it would be successful.

"Since this is the case, you should definitely head to the Mystic Pagoda and try to leave this place with him." Grandpa Lan said to them a moment later.

"Huh? You want to leave the Mystic Realm?" Yuan turned to look at Lan Yingying with slightly wide eyes since this is his first time hearing about it.

"Yes. After we deal with the demons, I plan to take you to the Mystic Pagoda to see if you can open it." Lan Yingying nodded.

"Does this mean you know how I can become the master of the Mystic Realm?"

Lan Yingying shook her head.

"I see... Then I will also try my best to find a way to help you leave." Yuan said.

Sometime later, they sat around the table while Grandma Lan prepared for the feast.

"I just realized this, but you took off your mask. You're a pretty handsome fellow, and this is coming from a magical beast with different standards. Why do you feel the need to hide your appearance?" Grandpa Lan asked him.

"Ah, I'm not really hiding because of my appearance. I'm mostly hiding since there are a lot of people who want to know my identity." Yuan said.

"Understandable. You're a very talented young man. There are bound to be countless people who are interested in you." Grandpa Lan nodded.

A moment later, Lan Yingying spoke, "By the way, Yuan, I have been wondering, do you have a special bloodline or something? Your blood... It's not normal."

"What do you mean?" Grandpa Lan was the first to speak, asking for more context.

"When I tasted his blood, it gave my body an unusual sensation; it was unlike anything I have experienced before, and even my cultivation base increased a little." Lan Yingying described her experience with Yuan's blood.

"What? Is that true?" Grandpa Lan then turned to look at Yuan with his curiosity peaked.

"Young man... If you don't mind, can I have a drop of your blood? I want to confirm my suspicions." He then asked.

Yuan nodded, "I don't mind."

He then poked a small hole in his finger and retrieved a drop of his blood before handing it to Grandpa Lan with Qi Manifestation.

After dropping the blood onto his tongue, Grandpa Lan closed his eyes and silently analyzed the blood.

A moment later, he opened his eyes with disbelief written all over his face.

"My lord... You really have a bloodline that's at the very least Divine-grade... This is also my first time tasting something this exquisite." Grandpa Lan mumbled in a dazed voice.

"Yingying, quickly, give the young man some of your blood!" Grandpa Lan said.

And he continued, "As Divine Beasts, our blood has the property to awaken human bloodlines!"

However, Yuan shook his head and said, "I have already tried that— with Phoenix blood."

"Eh? You tried to awaken lock your bloodline with Phoenix blood... and it didn't work?" Grandpa Lan looked at him with wide eyes.

Yuan nodded.

"Hmm..."

After a moment of silence, Grandpa Lan continued, "Although Phoenixes are at the top of the Divine Beasts' ranking, their blood isn't as powerful when it comes to awakening human bloodlines."

"That's where we— Divine Serpents— come in. Our blood can awaken most bloodlines in existence unless you have a God-like bloodline."

"God-like bloodlines?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"Only the most powerful families in the upper heavens would have a God bloodline."

"I see... Then let's try it." Yuan nodded.

Sometime later, Lan Yingying poured her own blood into a large cup until it was completely full before handing it to Yuan.

"T-This much?" Yuan was startled by the amount of blood that was in front of him at this moment.

"You probably only had a drop of Phoenix blood, right? A human can only handle so much Divine Beast blood no matter how powerful you are. If you consume too much, it'll harm you instead. However, our bloodline is a bit

unique in that aspect, as you can consume a large quantity without worrying about any harmful effects, and it'll even increase its effectiveness."

"I understand." Yuan nodded with a resolute look on his face.

He then took a deep breath before grabbing the cup of blood and chugging it down like a warrior.

After chugging the blood, Yuan could immediately feel his body heating up, similar to when he consumed Feng Yuxiang's Phoenix blood!

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Chapter 334 - Awakened Bloodline

"Argh! So hot!" Yuan exclaimed as his body grew warmer and warmer until it was smoking.

"A-Are you okay?!" Lan Yingying was startled when she saw this, feeling worried that something might have gone wrong.

"Calm down, Yingying. This means his bloodline is awakening." Grandpa Lan said to her in a calm voice.

And he continued, "Endure it, young man. If you lose consciousness, your bloodline won't awaken!"

Yuan nodded before making his way outside the cabin since it was much cooler there.

Once outside, he sat on the ground in the lotus position and tried to calm down by cultivating. However, the intense heat burning his body made things extremely difficult for him to stay focused.

"Akk!"

Yuan suddenly puked out a mouthful of blood, startling Lan Yingying.

"Are you sure he will be okay, grandfather? If my blood kills him... I don't think I can continue living with such guilt..."

Grandpa Lan didn't say anything and continued to watch Yuan with a serious expression on his face.

Rumble

"Hmm?" Grandpa Lan suddenly raised his eyebrows.

"Is it just me or is the ground shaking?"

"I feel it as well." Lan Yingying confirmed.

"It's been a while since we last had an earthquake." Grandpa Lan mumbled, not thinking too much of it at first.

However, the shaking did not stop like they'd expected it to sooner or later, and it was even gradually getting stronger.

"This isn't a normal earthquake. What's happening?" Grandpa Lan frowned upon realizing that this was an abnormal phenomenon.

Meanwhile, outside the Mystic Realm, the spectators realized that the gates to the Mystic Realm were shaking.

"L-Look at the Mystic Realm! It's shaking!"

"How is that possible? I don't feel any earthquakes!"

"Something must have happened inside the Mystic Realm!"

Upon closer inspection, they realized that the participants inside the Mystic Realm were experiencing an earthquake.

Senior Nie and the others from the Spirit Heaven frowned at this phenomenon, as they have never heard of the Mystic Realm acting like this before.

"Does anyone know what is happening?" One of the crystal balls asked.

"I have never heard of this before." One of them responded.

"Brother Yuan..." Xiao Hua mumbled his name in a low voice as she looked at the entrance to the Mystic Realm.

Inside the Mystic Realm, as the earthquake grew stronger, the people in that world began to worry that it might be the end of the world and that the Mystic Realm itself was collapsing, causing people to panic.

"What's going on?!" Grandma Lan stopped her cooking and went outside to see if they knew anything.

"We also have no idea what's going on right now." Grandpa Lan said.

"Hopefully it's nothing serious—"

"Ahhh!"

Yuan suddenly began screaming in a painful voice, and as though the world resonated with his pain, the earthquake shook even fiercer.

"T-This is... It can't be!" Grandpa Lan stared at Yuan with a dazed look on his face.

"Surely, he's not causing this earthquake from trying to awaken his bloodline, right?!"

"What?! Yuan's the cause of this earthquake?!" Lan Yingying exclaimed.

"I don't know yet, but there's a good chance, especially since it started shortly after he started awakening his bloodline. However, what kind of bloodline could possibly cause such a phenomenon?" Grandpa Lan mumbled.

[Attempting to awaken bloodline]

[...]

[...]

[...]

[Failed]

[Attempting to awaken bloodline]

[...]

[...]

[...]

[Failed]

[Attempting to awaken bloodline]

[...]

[...]

[...]

[Failed]

Yuan had expected the awakening to stop after three attempts like previously, but to his surprise, after his third failure, it continued to try and awaken his bloodline.

[Attempting to awaken bloodline]

[...]

[...]

[...]

[Failed]

Ten failures, twenty failures, fifty failures...

Sixth... seventy... eighty...

Ninety... Ninety-five... Ninety-nine...

After 99 attempts to awaken his bloodline and 99 failure, there was finally some change within the notifications.

[Attempting to awaken bloodline]

[Attempt successful]

[You have awakened your Bloodline!]

Ding!

[Immortal Monarch Bloodline]

[Grade: Royal]

[Description: You will obtain increased stats whenever your cultivation increases. Stats obtained from breakthroughs will also affect Soul Strength.]

"R-Royal-grade? How is that possible?" Yuan stared at his bloodline with disbelief on his face.

The lowest quality of bloodlines was Royal-grade and definitely below Divine-grade, but if that was the case, Feng Yuxiang's Phoenix blood should've been able to awaken it, so why does his bloodline show Royal-grade? Could it be a bug in the system? Or is there something special about this bloodline that he has yet to understand?

Once Yuan awakened his bloodline, the earthquake in the Mystic Realm also came to a halt.

"A-Are you okay, Yuan?!" Lan Yingying approached him with a worried look on her face.

"Yes... I am fine, thank you..." Yuan nodded his head, which was dripping with sweat.

"Thank the lord..." Lan Yingying released a deep sigh of relief to know that her blood didn't harm him.

"How about it, young man? Did you manage to awaken your bloodline?" Grandpa Lan asked him a moment later.

"Yes, I did. However... It's Royal-grade."

"What? Royal-grade? How is that possible? I tasted the blood myself! There's no way such powerful blood could only be Royal-grade!" Grandpa Lan expressed the same disbelief as Yuan after hearing the news.

"Can I taste your blood again just to make sure?" Grandpa Lan asked him.

Yuan nodded and quickly gave him a few drops of his own blood.

After tasting the blood, Grandpa Lan became even more puzzled, "I have tasted Royal-grade Bloodlines before, and this is definitely not Royal-grade."

"I-Is that so..." Yuan mumbled, believing this to be a bug in the game more and more.

Meanwhile, somewhere in this boundless universe, an old man with an ancient and timeless aura sat before a seemingly ordinary but massive jade tablet that had the word 'Destiny' carved into it, looking like he'd been in the same position for countless years.

The jade tablet that was almost a hundred times the old man's size suddenly began to glow, and the engraved word 'Destiny' began glowing golden.

The old man opened his eyes to look at the jade tablet with a sentimental feeling in his gaze.

"Alas... you have finally returned to us..."

The old man stood up a moment later and immediately knelt onto the ground before the jade tablet, kowtowing to it.

"Welcome back, Master... The Nine Heavens will soon tremble before your might once again... and for the final time..."

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Chapter 335 - Immortal Bloodlines

After kowtowing to the jade tablet for a couple of minutes, the old man stood up and patted his robes before turning around and walking away from the place.

"This subordinate will come to get you as soon as possible, Master..."

Meanwhile, back inside the Mystic Realm, Yuan sat around the table with the Lan Family as they began their feast.

"Good lord, you appear to have a bigger appetite than even us, Divine Beasts!" Grandma Lan exclaimed when Yuan displayed his eating talents before their very eyes for the first time.

"Hahaha! At this rate, you'll even eat our portions! Well, eat all you want! You're going to need all your strength when fighting the demons." Grandpa Lan said to him.

Sometime later, after the feast, Lan Yingying turned to look at Yuan and asked him, "Your bloodline awakened, right? Do you know what kind of bloodline you have?"

Yuan nodded and said, "Something called Immortal Monarch Bloodline."

"Pft!"

Grandpa Lan directly spat out the tea in his mouth after hearing Yuan's words.

"I-Immortal?! You have an Immortal bloodline?!" He looked at Yuan with disbelief in his gaze.

"There's no way an Immortal's bloodline could possibly be Royal-grade! I am certain about this now!" Grandpa Lan said.

"What's an Immortal's bloodline?" Yuan asked him.

"Immortal bloodlines are special bloodlines that can only be passed down by true Immortals in the highest realms at the upper heavens, and these bloodlines usually have heaven-defying powers that can turn even a normal human into a peak cultivation prodigy!" Grandpa Lan explained everything he knew about Immortal bloodlines.

"To tell you the truth, I don't know much about Immortals or Immortal bloodlines except that they are incredibly rare and powerful. If you have an Immortal bloodline, then you're definitely a descendant of a very powerful Cultivator."

"I see... Thank you for the information."

After the feast, Yuan logged off the game and waited for Meixiu to finish preparing dinner.

In the meantime, Yuan tried to see if there was any change to his body after consuming Lan Yingying's Divine Beast blood and awakening his bloodline.

However, he didn't feel any different than before his bloodline's awakening.

Sometime later, Meixiu went into his room with dinner.

"Yuan, did you feel the earthquake inside the Mystic Realm today?" Meixiu asked him.

"Eh? There was an earthquake? I didn't notice it..." Yuan said, as he was too focused on awakening his bloodline to notice the massive earthquake.

"The gates to the Mystic Realm suddenly began shaking yesterday, and it caused quite the stir among the spectators."

"I see..."

"You know the crazy part? Apparently, there was also an earthquake in this world sometime this afternoon. It was all over the news." Meixiu said.

"Wow, what a coincidence," Yuan mumbled.

After dinner, Meixiu went to sleep whilst Yuan went to cultivate.

However, for some reason, he felt extremely tired that night, falling asleep a few minutes later.

Furthermore, he had a dream that night— a weird dream where he stood before a massive jade tablet that was as large as a small mountain, and there was the word 'Destiny' engraved into this jade tablet.

"Geezer, I'm going to do it one last time."

An unfamiliar voice came from Yuan's mouth as he spoke— or more specifically, the body he was in spoke.

"How long do you think it'll take this time, Master?" An old voice resounded behind him.

And without turning around, the body Yuan was in spoke, "Who knows. It could be a thousand years from now. It could be a hundred thousand years from now. Hell, it could even be a million years. However, the moment this jade tablet glows, it means I have returned."

"This subordinate will wait for your return no matter how many millennia it may take," said the old voice.

After a moment of silence, the old voice returned, "Master, this may be out of my line, but do you intend on telling 'her' about your departure?"

"I don't..." He immediately responded, and he continued, "I'm sure that she'll be angry at me for keeping her in the dark about this, but I don't want to disturb her cultivation. She's very close to becoming a true Immortal, and any distractions might take that away from her."

"Geezer, if she makes a scene, just let her know what I told you— that I will be back for you guys no matter what."

"Anyways, I'm going to leave now. I'll see you later, Geezer."

It was at this point of the dream when Yuan woke up.

'What a weird dream...' He thought to himself.

However, despite this being his first time experiencing such a dream, he felt oddly nostalgic, almost like he'd seen that exact scene before.

Furthermore, he realized that his limbs became more responsive in the morning, allowing him to move his fingers with less effort. If he tried, he could even lift his arm and legs a little off the bed!

Yuan was filled with excitement by this change, and his anticipation for the future grew some more.

Sometime later, Meixiu entered his room to do her daily routine.

"Yuan, let's give you a wash before you play," Meixiu said to him, as it has been some time since she last cleaned him.

"Okay," Yuan said.

Inside the bathroom, whilst Meixiu scrubbed his body down with her soapy hands, Yuan suddenly spoke, "Meixiu, do you know how to make babies?"

"Eh?"

Meixiu nearly slipped on the wet floor after hearing Yuan's sudden question.

"B-Babies? Why are you asking?" She responded in a stiff voice with her face heating up quickly.

"Well, I was in this situation that required me to make babies. However, that person was not human, so the methods were a bit unique, and I have been

curious about it since then." Yuan revealed his experience in the Mystic Realm to Meixiu, greatly shocking her.

"D-Did you do it? Make babies with this person, I mean..." Meixiu decided to ask him.

"Yes, I did." Yuan calmly responded, and he continued, "She's a Divine Beast, so it'll take a thousand years for her to give birth— at least that's what she told me."

"..."

Meixiu became speechless after hearing Yuan confirm that he had indeed impregnated another entity in the game!

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Chapter 336 - How To Make Babies

"L-Let me get this straight... You impregnated an NPC in the game?"
Meixiu asked again just in case.

"That's what she told me," Yuan responded in a calm voice, not thinking too much about it.

"Heavens..." Meixiu mumbled in a dazed voice. She cannot imagine how Yu Rou would react once she learns of this.

'Perhaps it would be better if I don't tell her... for her own sake...' Meixiu thought to herself.

After a moment of silence, she said, "Yuan... I know the Yu Family didn't teach you this, but you really shouldn't impregnate women so easily, especially if you just met them."

"I know that, but these people are really nice, and I really wanted to help them," Yuan said.

"Let's continue this talk after this. My mother will kill me if you catch a cold because I didn't take care of you properly."

"Okay."

Thus, Meixiu continued to clean Yuan's body, but her heart felt heavier than usual, almost like there were invisible chains weighing it down.

'It's just an NPC so it should be fine... And it's only a game...' Meixiu thought to herself as she moved her hands to the thing between Yuan's legs.

'Making babies, huh? I guess it's about time he learns about these kinds of things...'

Because the Yu Family only cared about his musical talents, they didn't want anything that wasn't music-related to enter his brain, and that included common sense for even the basic things in life.

After all, the less common sense Yuan had, the easier it was for them to control him and trick him.

As for things regarding the opposite sex, that never even crossed the Yu Family's mind. Of course, Yu Rou taught him some common sense, but she wanted Yuan to remain innocent and pure for as long as possible, so she purposefully avoided talking about these kinds of things.

After cleaning Yuan's body, she brought him back to his room where she dried his body some more and changed his clothes.

"You want to learn how to make babies, right?" Meixiu asked him afterward.

"Yes."

"Well, first and foremost, you need to understand the importance of having babies with another individual. Having a baby isn't something you can take lightly, Yuan, as it will affect you for the rest of your life. Luckily, it only happened inside the game, but if it was the real world, you will have a lot of responsibility to bear."

"Furthermore, you should only have babies with your significant other—someone you care enough about that you wouldn't mind spending the rest of your life with them," Meixiu said to him.

Hearing Meixiu's words, Yuan suddenly spoke, "So someone like you?"

"Eh?"

Meixiu was at a loss for words after hearing Yuan's words that took her completely by surprise and also made her body shiver.

And Yuan suddenly continued, "I wouldn't mind spending the rest of my life with you, Meixiu. Does this make you my significant other?"

"W-Well... N-Not exactly..." Meixiu responded in a trembling voice.

"Having a significant other requires an agreement between two people that want to be with each other. You cannot just call someone your significant other because you want to be with them." Meixiu explained to him.

"I see..." Yuan mumbled.

"Anyways, now that you know not to have a baby with every female you meet, let's talk about the process of making babies."

After taking a deep breath, Meixiu continued, "In order to make babies, a man needs to connect bodies with a female, or more specifically, use the thing between their legs to connect with the female's body."

"What! You can use that thing to make babies?! I thought it was only for peeing!" Yuan exclaimed in a truly surprised tone after learning this revelation.

"It's actually a little more complicated than that, but yes, that's the gist of it... And such an act is called... having sex..." Meixiu said, somehow managing to keep a straight face as she educated Yuan on this kind of topic.

"Anyways, this is the basics of having babies. Do you have any questions?" Meixiu said to him.

"This is just the basics? Heavens, I never knew it would be so complicated." Yuan mumbled.

And he continued, "Thank you for telling me, Meixiu. I have learned a lot today, and it's just the beginning of the day."

"Don't mention it... You would've learned it sooner or later even without me, anyway." Meixiu said.

Sometime later, Meixiu returned to her room after helping Yuan enter the game.

'He doesn't mind spending the rest of his life with me, huh?'

A warm smile appeared on Meixiu's beautiful face as she placed the helmet on her head.

After entering the game, Meixiu looked at Feng Yuxiang and spoke to her, "Feng Feng, I have a question."

"What is it?"

"How do Divine Beasts make babies? And can they really mate with humans?" Meixiu asked her, as this has been on her mind ever since Yuan told her about it.

"W-What? Why are you asking me such questions?" Feng Yuxiang looked at her with wide eyes.

"I'm... I'm just curious..." Meixiu said.

"Well... Different species have different methods of mating with each other, but in general, most Divine Beasts only require blood and spiritual energy to conceive a child." Feng Yuxiang said a moment later.

"Is this the same with humans?"

Feng Yuxiang nodded, "That's right. Divine Beasts can indeed mate with humans, but such a situation is very rare since most Divine Beasts see humans as inferior beings."

After a moment of silence, Meixiu continued to ask, "What happens if a human and a Divine Beast mate with each other like humans do— by having sex? Can they conceive that way?"

Feng Yuxiang's jaw dropped after hearing Meixiu's question. Why was she asking such weird questions? Is this related to the Young Master?

"If a human and Divine Beast have... ahem... sex... It's usually only for pleasure, as it's more efficient to mate using blood and spiritual energy since it's always almost guaranteed to impregnate them." Feng Yuxiang said to her.

"I see..." Meixiu mumbled, realizing that she might have misunderstood Yuan because of his lack of context.

Meanwhile, the others were completely baffled by their conversation that was completely random and out of place.

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Chapter 337 - Abandoned Valley

Inside the Mystic Realm, Yuan and the Lan Family gathered outside the cabin.

"We're going to invade the demons today. Are you all prepared?" Grandpa Lan asked them.

Once everyone there nodded, Grandpa Lan continued, "I'll carry all of you in my beast form."

A moment later, he transformed into a massive white serpent, and compared to Lan Yingying, he was at least ten times larger— large enough to wrap around an entire mountain with ease!

Yuan was slightly surprised to see Grandpa Lan's beast form, but compared to the Great One that was literally countless times larger than a star, it wasn't too shocking.

When everyone jumped onto his back, Grandpa Lan suddenly levitated off the ground and began slithering in the air!

A flying snake— it was a sight to behold.

"L-Look at the sky! What on earth is that?!" One of the participants— a player stared at the sky in shock as he witnessed a massive snake slithering through the clouds like a dragon!

"Heavens! Is that a dragon?!"

Many of the participants mistook Grandpa Lan as a dragon.

"No, that's a serpent! It's a magical beast! But I have never seen anything like that before!"

"Since it's flying it must be at least a Spirit Grandmaster, right?! There are such powerful beings in the Mystic Realm?!"

Half of the participants in the Mystic Realm saw the flying serpent in the sky because of Grandpa Lan's massive size and the distance they traveled.

Of course, the spectators outside the Mystic Realm also saw the massive snake in the sky.

"What kind of magical beast is that? I don't recall ever seeing such a magical beast before in the Mystic Realm." Senior Nie asked the people on the other side of the crystal balls.

"No idea. I don't remember seeing such a magical beast before, either."

"Well, the Mystic Realm is still filled with mysteries even though we've explored it many times."

"Actually... Rumor has it that there exists a Divine Beast somewhere within the Mystic Realm... Could that be it?" One of them suddenly said.

"What? A Divine Beast? As if that's possible!" Another voice scoffed.

A couple of hours later, Grandpa Lan landed in a desolate area and transformed back to his human form.

"We're going to be traveling by foot here since we don't want to alert the demons that are hiding deep within the Abandoned Valley just yet." He said to them.

As they walked, Grandpa Lan continued, "Once we confront the demons, I will be dealing with the Demon Lord, leaving the other three demons in your hands. I'd like to take on another one, but I'll have my hands full with just the Demon Lord."

"I can take care of two demons by myself since they're nowhere near as powerful as the Demon Lord. Young man, Yingying, the both of you will take care of the last one. Once you deal with that one, I'll need you to help me kill the other two demons since I don't have the ability to kill them." Grandma Lan said.

The two of them nodded.

"Yuan, I'll distract the demon while you strike it with your demon sealing technique. They have no idea that you know such a technique, and we're going to use that fact to our advantage." Lan Yingying said to him.

"Okay." Yuan nodded

After navigating through the dead valley for another three hours, they reached the deepest parts of the valley.

"It's weird how we haven't run into any magical beasts," Yuan mumbled.

"That's because the demons hunted them all." Grandpa Lan said.

"Demons don't care if they are humans or magical beasts— they will hunt them as long as it increases their cultivation. Hell, they will even hunt other demons if necessary."

"Their aggressive nature and insatiable hunger for strength is the main reason they're a danger to all living beings and why they were eventually hunted."

"How are demons born?" Yuan suddenly asked.

"Honestly, I can't tell you since I don't know. Demons have been around since ancient times and not much is known about them. Perhaps you'll find such information in the upper heavens, but in the Lower Heavens, I doubt anyone knows."

"I see..."

Sometime later, Grandpa Lan said, "I can sense them."

And he continued, "However, they can also sense us. I'm going to distract the Demon Lord first."

After saying such words, Grandpa Lan turned into his beast form and immediately flew into the sky.

"Hahaha! I didn't think you'd come here on your own accord, sparing us the effort of breaking into the Divine Forest!" A deep voice filled with malice suddenly echoed, followed by a powerful aura that immediately made the atmosphere suffocating.

A moment later, Yuan could see the figure emitting this powerful aura flying towards Grandpa Lan in the skies.

"That's the Demon Lord?" Yuan mumbled with a dazed look.

This demon looked almost like the demon he defeated, except that he was much more muscular and the red crystal in its chest was much larger and had a deeper color than the previous demon. Of course, it was also much more powerful and more dangerous.

This Demon Lord reminded him of someone— that red-haired cultivator who was fighting in the skies right before Xiao Hua became his servant—the same person he learned the Bloody Sword Strike from, as they both emitted an evil-feeling aura.

A moment later, three more demons could be seen flying in the sky, but they were not looking at Grandpa Lan. Instead, their gazes were directly on Yuan and the others.

"You brought a human here to assist you? Hahaha! How desperate are you?!" The three demons laughed for a moment before landing a few meters away from them, each of them emitting an aura more powerful than the demon Yuan killed previously.

"It's been many years since I last tasted human blood! How fortunate! I'll take care of the human and the little princess! The two of you can take care

of that granny!" The demon in the center spoke with a massive grin on its face.

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Chapter 338 - As If SuChapter A Toy Could Injure Me!

"Make sure to save some of that human's blood for us, and try not to kill the little princess. The Lord would like to have some fun with her before chewing on her meat and drinking her blood." Another demon said.

"Yuan... follow me..." Lan Yingying suddenly mumbled to Yuan.

Once Yuan nodded his head, Lan Yingying turned around and began running away. Seeing this, Yuan also turned around and followed her.

"Where the hell do you think you're running off to when you were the ones who came here first, you little shits?!"

The demon standing in the front immediately began chasing after Yuan and Lan Yingying.

Grandma Lan didn't even bother to block this demon and allowed it to chase after them.

When the other two demons saw this, their eyebrows raised.

Grandma Lan smiled and said, "They don't need my help. What's more, I already have my hands full with you little demons..."

After saying that, she transformed into a large serpent with green scales that resembled jade.

"What are you going to do?"

"Even if we cannot defeat you, you won't be able to kill us either."

The two demons chuckled after seeing Grandma Lan transform.

Meanwhile, in the skies, the Demon Lord spoke as it hovered before Grandpa Lan, "Do you really believe that you'll be able to defeat us because you attacked us before we attacked you? Because we're not prepared?"

And it continued, "Did you already forget what happened last time you tried to invade us by surprise? You lost your son and his partner. This time, you'll lose your wife, your granddaughter, and your own life!"

After a moment of silence, Grandpa Lan spoke, "I remember very well what happened. Their death was unfortunate, but we'd managed to reduce your kind by more than half. This time... we're going to kill all of you and clean up the Mystic Realm."

The smile on the Demon Lord's face immediately turned upside down after hearing Grandpa Lan's words, and it spoke in a grim voice, "Let me see you try!"

Boom!

The Demon Lord exploded with a massive aura, and it rushed at Grandpa Lan.

"Sacred Fire!"

Grandpa Lan opened his mouth and spat out fire flames at the Demon Lord.

"Scatter!"

The Demon Lord used its bare hands to punch the white flames, causing it to scatter all over the place and making it rain small fireballs all over the place.

Thus, the Demon Lord began fighting Grandpa Lan in the skies.

Meanwhile, Lan Yingying and Yuan continued to run away until they were many miles away from the others.

"How long do you plan on running for?! Did you come all the way here just to abandon those old people?!" The demon shouted at them as it chased after them.

A few more minutes later, Lan Yingying finally stopped running and turned around.

"We can stop now, Yuan."

The demon also came to a sudden halt and stared at them with narrowed eyes, wondering what they're planning.

'Yuan, I'm going to distract it as planned. Strike it with your sealing technique when you see the chance,' Lan Yingying said to him using Divine Sense.

Yuan nodded his head.

After taking a deep breath, Lan Yingying turned into her beast form and immediately rushed at the demon.

"Oh? You're going to attack me by yourself? Did you bring that human just to spectate?" The demon was surprised when Yuan stayed behind whilst Lan Yingying attacked it alone.

Pap!

Lan Yingying used her tail like a whip, attacking the demon with it and cracking the air on impact.

The demon didn't even bother to avoid the attack and merely used its arms to block it.

Boom!

The demon was sent flying off into the distance from the impact, but it didn't sustain any injuries in the end.

"Haha! Come at me! Entertain me for a bit before I kill that human!"

The demon and Lan Yingying began attacking each other, quickly turning the scene into a mess.

"Little princess, your parents were a treat. My body still trembles when I recall how delicious their meat tasted. I wonder how you'll taste..." The demon licked its lips, treating its fight with Lan Yingying as a joke, almost like it was playing around with her.

"Shut up!" Lan Yingying's attacks immediately grew more aggressive, clearly agitated by the demon's words.

"Ahaha! Are you angry, little princess?! Do you want to kill me?! Unfortunately, you don't have the power to kill me! And in just a moment, you'll witness those two old bastards enter our stomachs!"

The demon continued to provoke Lan Yingying.

A few minutes later, once the demon was fully absorbed in fighting Lan Yingying, it forgot about Yuan's seemingly insignificant presence.

"Sacred Fire!" Lan Yingying opened her mouth and released a torrent of white flames at the demon, who didn't even bother to dodge it.

"You don't learn, do you?! You won't be able to injure me with such weak flames, much less kill me!"

The demon patted the white flames off its body as though it was mere dust.

"I've spent enough time messing with you. I would love to eat you right here and now, but alas, the Demon Lord would kill me if I do, so I'll have to endure not it and not kill you—"

The demon suddenly stopped talking when it felt something pierce its body, causing it to look down.

"Huh?"

The demon raised its eyebrows when it saw a huge sword piercing its body from the back.

It turned around to look at the masked figure standing behind it with an annoyed expression on its face, and it spoke in a calm voice, "What the fuck do you think you're doing, human? You should've run away when you had the chance. I had even forgotten about you since your presence is akin to an ant."

However, Yuan didn't say anything and merely pulled the Empyrean Overlord out of the demon's body and took a few steps back.

"Hmph! What a joke. As if such a toy could injure me!" The demon looked at Yuan with clear disdain on its face.

"Are you sure about that?" Yuan spoke as he pointed to the demon's body.

"What?"

The demon looked down, and to its surprise, the hole in its body wasn't regenerating at all! In fact, it was even turning into stone!

"W-What the heck is happening?! What the fuck did you do to me just now, human?!" The demon roared at Yuan with veins all over its face.

Yuan shrugged and said, "It was nothing much— just a demon sealing technique."

"A what?!" The demon was shocked after hearing Yuan's words.

Once it realized the situation, it roared in anger, "Damn you, human! You must be from the Demon Sealing Clan! What is someone like you doing here?!"

Unlike the demon Yuan previously sealed, this demon was still able to move and release its aura after being struck by the Demon Sealing Strike, most likely because it was much more powerful than the previous demon.

However, the petrifying effect was still spreading, and it appeared to be spreading much quicker than before. After all, Yuan was also much stronger than before.

"Fuck, fuck, fuck! I curse you, human! I curse you, Demon Sealing Clan—"

Alas, the demon wasn't able to finish its last sentence before being sealed by the Demon Sealing Strike.

"Yuan, let's leave this demon alone for now so we can help my grandparents. We can finish it off afterward." Lan Yingying said to him.

And she continued, "This way, we won't alert the other demons. Once sealed, they won't be able to move for at least a few hundred years."

Yuan nodded, and they proceeded to return to Grandma Lan's side.

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Chapter 339 - Key To Mystic Pagoda

Crack

Pap

Boom!

Grandma Lan used her tail like a whip, sending the demons flying whenever they tried to get close to her.

"Did you come here just to play around?! As if such weak attacks could kill us!" The demons would return to her no matter how many times they were sent flying by her tail.

However, Grandma Lan ignored them and continued to buy time for Yuan and Lan Yingying, as they were her only hope in killing them.

In the sky, Grandpa Lan and the Demon Lord also exchanged hundreds of blows with each other in just a few minutes.

"Old snake, you guys lost your chance to kill us off when that damn human failed to kill us hundreds of thousands of years ago! Even if your bloodline continues for many generations, you will never be able to defeat us!" The Demon Lord laughed out loud.

The demons were the oldest entities in the Mystic Realm, as they have survived for hundreds of thousands of years— even before the Lord became the master of the Mystic Realm. However, despite living for so long, their cultivation hasn't improved by much, mostly because they can only grow so much with the limited amount of spiritual energy in the Mystic Realm,

hence why they want to break out of the Mystic Realm so badly— so that they can continue to grow.

No matter how much time they're given, if they do not have enough spiritual energy for a breakthrough, their cultivation will remain unchanging.

"Once we take care of your family, we'll kill all of the humans in this damned world! Eventually, we'll find a way to enter the Mystic Pagoda and open the seal that has locked us in this world for far too long!"

"Hahaha! You want to leave the Mystic Realm? In your dreams, Demon Lord! Even if you manage to kill all of us, you'll never be able to enter the Mystic Pagoda! Do you know why? Because you don't have the key! Hahaha!"

"Key? What are you talking about?!" The Demon Lord immediately frowned, as this is its first time hearing about a key being required to open the Mystic Realm.

"You want to know? Too bad! That's as much as you'll know about the Mystic Pagoda!" Grandpa Lan laughed.

In truth, Grandpa Lan didn't know anything about the Mystic Pagoda, and he'd only mentioned a 'key' just to mess with the Demon Lord.

Of course, the Demon Lord didn't think it was being lied to as what Grandpa Lan said was quite logical.

"Tell me about this damn key!!!"

The Demon Lord roared, its aura increasing to a whole new level as it started getting serious.

"Make me!"

Grandpa Lan's aura also rose.

When their auras collided, it created an immense pressure in the area that made the dead trees sink a little deeper into the ground.

Meanwhile, at Grandma Lan's area, when the demons noticed the Demon Lord getting serious, they also turned serious.

"Looks like it's about time we stop playing around and kill you once and for all."

The demons emitted an ominous aura that caused the dirt around them to turn black.

"No matter how many times you attack us, we won't die. Why don't you just give up and let us give you a painful death? Or, you can struggle and we'll eat you alive."

However, a mysterious smile appeared on Grandma Lan's face, and she spoke, "Indeed, we should probably end this."

"Blood Spear!"

The demons summoned a red spear using their blood.

"Get her!"

Just as the demons prepared to attack Grandma Lan, one of the demons felt an immense pressure suddenly appeared behind it, causing it to stop and turn around.

"What?"

The demon mumbled in a dumbfounded voice as a figure wearing a black mask swung the massive sword in his hand horizontally, slicing its body in half.

"Where the fuck did this human come from? And what happened to the one chasing after him?" The other demon was as surprised when it realized that its partner had been attacked out of the blue. However, the demon wasn't

worried about its partner, as it was confident that such a minor injury wouldn't be able to kill it.

As for the demon sliced in half, it frowned when it realized that its body wasn't regenerating.

"What's going on?!" The demon exclaimed a moment later.

However, Yuan didn't respond to it and turned his attention to the second demon.

"I admire your guts for returning to his place, but it was a foolish choice, human! This is not a battle you can just enter as you please! You don't qualify to stand on the same battlefield as us!" The demon shouted as it tossed the spear in its grasp at Yuan.

Yuan immediately used his movement technique to dodge the spear before approaching the demon.

"Haha! What are you going to do with that sword—" The demon's eyes widened with shock when it finally paid some attention to the Empyrean Overlord in Yuan's grasp.

However, before it could even continue, Yuan stabbed the sword in-between its chest.

Meanwhile, the other demon that had its body sliced in half was turning into stone.

"Ahh! What is going on?! What is happening to my body?!" The demon cried out loud.

"T-This is—! A sealing technique?!" The second demon was shocked to see this, and it looked down at the sword in its chest with a fearful expression.

"D-Don't tell me..."

Yuan didn't say anything and pulled the sword out of its body, letting the petrifying effect spread throughout its body.

"You came back faster than I'd anticipated, young man, just like the first time." Grandma Lan said to him with a smile on her face.

"I'm sorry I couldn't return faster," Yuan said.

"Fuck! My body! Why?! Why is someone from the Demon Sealing Clan here?! And that sword! You must be—!" The two demons looked at Yuan with fear in their eyes, something they haven't experienced since the Lord left the Mystic Realm.

Meanwhile, in the air, the Demon Lord noticed something was amiss and turned to look at the ground where Yuan and the others were.

When it noticed Yuan and the Empyrean Overlord in his hands, the Demon Lord's eyes widened with shock, and it roared in a spiteful voice, "That sword! Impossible! You— You have returned?!"

Chapter 340 - The Lords Sword

Chapter 340 - The Lord's Sword

"What are you talking about?" Grandpa Lan looked at the Demon Lord with a puzzled expression.

However, the Demon Lord completely ignored Grandpa Lan and continued to stare at Yuan's figure with disbelief.

"A mask! That sword! After so many years, you have finally decided to return to the Mystic Realm— Lord!" A massive smile appeared on the Demon Lord's face, but there was also a hint of fear in its eyes.

"What?!" Grandpa Lan exclaimed in a shocked voice when he heard the Demon Lord addressed Yuan as 'Lord'.

"I won't forget the humiliation you had put me through on that day no matter how many years passes, Lord!" The Demon Lord suddenly flew towards Yuan's location.

"Watch out!" Grandpa Lan shouted loudly to warn Yuan and the others of the Demon Lord's presence.

"Huh?" Yuan turned around at Grandpa Lan's voice, and to his surprise, the Demon Lord in the sky was flying in their direction!

BOOM!

The Demon Lord punched Yuan with all of its might, as it didn't want to risk this chance to take him by surprise.

Luckily for Yuan, Grandpa Lan had warned him right before the Demon Lord made his strike, giving him a split second to react and protect himself with the Empyrean Overlord.

However, the impact was an entirely different matter, and Yuan was sent flying many meters away, crashing into trees and destroying them with his back.

Yuan managed to stabilize himself after flying about two hundred meters.

Cough

He coughed up a mouthful of blood afterward.

'What a powerful strike! If I hadn't blocked that attack, I would've probably died just now!' Yuan's body trembled at that thought, yet his eyes didn't have even a hint of fear within them.

Instead, it flickered with excitement, as he has never been pushed to such an extent before.

"Yuan! Are you okay?!" Lan Yingying quickly approached him.

"Yes, I'm fine." Yuan nodded.

"Yuan? Wait a second, you're not the Lord. Who are you? And where did you get that sword?" The Demon Lord finally noticed Yuan's cultivation base that was too low to be the Lord and stopped its assault.

A second later, both grandparents stood between Yuan and the Demon Lord.

"If that young man was the Lord, he would've killed you as easily as breathing!" Grandpa Lan said.

"Then he must be a descendant of the Lord! After all, that sword in his hand belongs to the Lord!" The Demon Lord revealed, as it will never forget the devastation that sword had caused the demons.

"What?! Really?!"

The Lan Family expressed shock upon learning this since even they didn't know that the sword in Yuan's hand once belonged to the Lord!

'Is that why I felt some sort of connection to it?' Lan Yingying finally realized why she was attracted to the sword. It turned out to be the Lord's sword.

"So the Sword Emperor is the Lord?" Yuan mumbled.

Does this mean the Sword Emperor is dead? After all, Feng Yuxiang mentioned that she found the Empyrean Overlord in a Legacy Tomb, where powerful cultivators leave their legacy behind because they are close to death.

"That's not possible—he cannot be the Lord's descendant! We have already tested his blood!" Grandpa Lan said.

The Demon Lord turned to look at the two demons that had been sealed by Yuan.

"Then you must be someone from the Demon Sealing Clan that's also affiliated with the Lord. In any case, I cannot and will not let you leave this place alive." It glared at him with a bloodthirsty gaze.

"Blood Sword!"

The Demon Lord summoned its weapon using its own blood.

"Even if there are four of you, it won't be enough to kill me, especially if the Lord isn't with you." The Demon Lord began approaching them with its aura growing stronger and stronger.

"Young man, we're going to distract it while you look for the opportunity to strike it with the demon sealing strike," Grandpa Lan said to him.

"Okay." Yuan nodded.

"Let's go, grandma. Yingying, you stay behind. There's nothing you can do here."

Even though Lan Yingying didn't want to admit it, she truly did not qualify to be in this battle.

A few seconds later, both of the grandparents went to attack the Demon Lord.

"Hahaha! Are you trying to distract me while that human waits for the chance to seal me? I am not as foolish as the other demons!" The Demon Lord laughed out loud as it began fighting the two snakes.

And whenever it had the chance, it would throw an attack at Yuan to let him know that it was keeping track of him.

"I'm going to fight it." Yuan suddenly said after some time.

"What? You can't! The Demon Lord is on another level! You won't be able to get close to him, much less attack him!" Lan Yingying said.

"Perhaps not at my current level, but if I increase my cultivation somehow..." Yuan spoke as he turned to look at the sealed demons not far away from them.

"What do you plan on doing?" Lan Yingying asked him.

"I'm going to kill them and eat their demon cores..." Yuan replied, shocking her.

"Are you serious?!" She looked at him with wide eyes.

Yuan nodded, "If it's true that the founder of the Demon Sealing Clan was able to eat demon cores, I should be able to do the same since I have the same physique."

"But that's just a rumor— a legend! Demon cores are completely different from monster cores! It's too dangerous" Lan Yingying said.

"It may be risky, but we won't know unless I try it." Yuan said, and he continued, "Don't worry, I have a feeling that everything will work out just fine."

Lan Yingying opened her mouth, but alas, she decided to not say anything and let him try to eat the demon cores.

A moment later, Yuan pointed the Empyrean Overlord at the sealed demons and took a deep breath, preparing to use the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike on them.

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Chapter 341 - Perfect Regeneration

"What do you think you're doing?!" The Demon Lord immediately noticed Yuan gathering his spiritual energy, clearly preparing for an attack, and it immediately rushed at him.

However, the grandparents also went to block its path.

"You think you can just ignore us?"

Pap!

Grandpa Lan slapped the Demon Lord with its powerful tail, sending it further away from Yuan.

"Get out of my way—" Just as the Demon Lord roared, Yuan released the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike, completely missing the Demon Lord.

"Hahaha! Where the hell are you aiming?" The Demon Lord laughed in a slightly nervous tone afterward, as it felt the immense power within the strike released by Yuan just now.

'If that thing had hit me, I would've been in danger! This human is truly too dangerous to be left alive! Luckily, this human doesn't have any control over it!' The Demon Lord cried inwardly, thinking that Yuan had only missed because he doesn't have full control over the technique.

However, it suddenly noticed that Yuan wasn't even paying attention to it. Instead, he went to where the sealed demons were before they were 'accidentally' struck by the attack and picked up their demon cores.

'What the hell is he doing?' The Demon Lord raised its eyebrows at Yuan's puzzling actions.

A moment later, Yuan tossed one of the demon cores in his mouth, shocking the Demon Lord and the grandparents.

"Hahaha! What is that idiot doing?! Does he want to kill himself?! That makes things much easier for me!" The Demon Lord burst out laughing like a maniac after witnessing Yuan's actions.

"Young man! What are you doing?!" Grandpa Lan exclaimed.

While he knew that Yuan could consume monster cores, he was still shocked speechless by Yuan's actions just now. After all, demon cores are completely different from monster cores. If eating monster cores is akin to drinking water, then eating demon cores is akin to drinking alcohol!

Meanwhile, Yuan could feel his tongue beginning to burn after consuming the demon core.

"Demon cores are spicy!" Yuan exclaimed, recalling the first time he accidentally ate spicy food. However, the demon core was spicier than anything he's ever experienced before, feeling like he'd just poured a bottle of hot sauce in his mouth!

[Heaven Refining Physique Activated]

[??? Qi has been absorbed from the Demon Core]

[You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough]

[You have reached first level Spirit Grandmaster]

[+Stats 25,000]

Ding!

[Your body has cleansed the impurities from the Demon Core]

[Demon core has been refined]

[Your skill 'Superior Regeneration' has developed into 'Perfect Regeneration']

[Perfect Regeneration]

[Rank: Divine]

[Description: Can restore even a missing limb]

When the Demon Lord, who was waiting for Yuan to explode from consuming the demon core, realized that Yuan was perfectly fine, even experiencing a breakthrough from it, the Demon Lord nearly lost its mind from shock.

"What?! That's impossible! How can a mere human consume a demon core?! You should've died the moment you ate it!" The Demon Lord exclaimed in a voice filled with bewilderment.

However, Yuan ignored the Demon Lord and proceeded to consume the second demon core.

[Heaven Refining Physique Activated]

[??? Qi has been absorbed from the Demon Core]

[You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough]

[You have reached second level Spirit Grandmaster]

[+Stats 26,000]

[You have reached third level Spirit Grandmaster]

[+Stats 27,000]

[Your body has cleansed the impurities from the Demon Core]

'Fuck! It wasn't a fluke that he survived the first demon core?!' The Demon Lord was hoping that Yuan was only lucky enough to survive at first, but

after witnessing him consume a second demon core, it concluded that it was not coincidence or luck that Yuan could eat demon cores.

'Is this human really human?! How can a human survive the chaotic spiritual energy within a demon core?! Even a demon would go mad if it consumes a demon core! He's even more dangerous than the Lord in some ways!'

"So this is what being a Spirit Grandmaster feels like, huh? As expected, my body is filled with energy, and it feels like I won't lose no matter what I'm fighting." Yuan mumbled to himself before turning to look at the Demon Lord who was staring at him with its face twisted in disbelief.

"I wonder how your demon core will taste, Demon Lord." Yuan suddenly said to it, causing a chill to go down the Demon Lord's back.

"Try to get my demon core if you can, you damn monster!"

The Demon Lord roared before it rushed at Yuan with the bloody sword in its grasp.

"Oh no! Watch out, young man!"

The grandparents reacted a little slow this time around, mostly because they were still shocked by Yuan's unbelievable appetite, allowing the Demon Lord to slip right through them.

"I'll be okay!" Yuan said to them as he raised the Empyrean Overlord and welcomed the Demon Lord.

Once it was close enough to strike, the Demon Lord swung its blood sword at Yuan.

Boom!

Yuan blocked the attack with his own sword, causing the ground to shake from the impact.

However, unlike previously, he wasn't sent flying.

Furthermore, the blood sword in the Demon Lord's grasp even cracked a little!

The Demon Lord sucked its teeth before quickly repairing the sword with its blood.

"Blood Arms!"

The Demon Lord suddenly grew two arms behind its back.

"Blood Sword!"

Then two swords appeared in those arms.

"Die for me!"

The Demon Lord struck Yuan again, this time with two extra swords.

Yuan immediately used his movement technique to dodge the strikes before activating Heavenly Domain, restricting the Demon Lord's movements to a small extent.

"Four arms? That's not fair!" Yuan exclaimed after dodging its strikes.

"Hmph! You don't get to say such words after what you just did! Are you really human? Damn monster in human skin!" The Demon Lord said to him.

"Young man! Are you okay?!"

The grandparents returned to his side after their quick clash.

"I'm okay, and let me fight the demon alone," Yuan said to them.

"Y-You want to fight it by yourself?" Grandpa Lan looked at him with a dazed face.

Chapter 342 - Fighting The Demon Lord

"I fight better when there's nobody around me since I can let loose without needing to worry about hitting you guys as well," Yuan said to them.

"I-I understand... If you think you can defeat it by yourself, we won't get in your way. But if I sense that you're in danger, I'll immediately assist you." Grandpa Lan said to him before returning to his human form.

"You want to fight me alone? Hahaha! Don't get cocky just because your cultivation improved slightly! You're still only a Spirit Grandmaster whilst I am a Spirit Lord! There's still a vast gap between us!" The Demon Lord laughed as its aura continued to rise.

Yuan didn't wait any longer and rushed at the Demon Lord, striking it with his Empyrean Overlord.

Clang!

The Demon Lord used two of its swords to block Yuan's strike whilst using its third one to retaliate.

Yuan then used his movement technique to dance around the Demon Lord. Despite being an entire realm above Yuan, the Demon Lord still had its movements suppressed by the Heavenly Domain.

"What an annoying movement technique!" The Demon Lord didn't dare to waste its movements while being restricted and waited for Yuan to strike, as a single mistake might cost its life.

[Bloody Sword Strike!]

Yuan suddenly attacked the Demon Lord after a minute of trying to confuse it with his movement technique.

However, even though the Demon Lord couldn't move at its full speed, its reaction remained in peak condition, allowing it to defend against Yuan's strike even though its movements were slowed.

The two of them continued to dance back and forth with Yuan being on the offensive and the Demon Lord on the defensive for many minutes.

'Fuck! How long can he keep this restriction domain active?! How much spiritual energy does he have?!' The Demon Lord cried inwardly, as it had been waiting for Yuan to exhaust his spiritual energy.

After all, to sustain such a powerful pressure that could restrict even a Spirit Lord's movements, it would obviously require an immense amount of Qi.

However, many minutes have passed without any signs of Yuan exhausting his spiritual energy.

Half an hour later, the Demon Lord roared, "Don't tell me you have unlimited energy as well?!"

The Demon Lord decided to risk it and flew into the sky, where the Heavenly Domain could not reach him.

Yuan narrowed his eyes at the Demon Lord in the sky. Although he could also fly, he wasn't confident enough in his flight abilities to fight someone like the Demon Lord in the skies.

"Blood Spears!"

The Demon Lord suddenly summoned a dozen spears with its blood before throwing them at Yuan.

Yuan immediately used his movement technique to dodge them, but the Demon Lord continued to summon the spears, raining them down on him.

"You think you're the only one with inexhaustible spiritual energy?! I can do this all day!" The Demon Lord laughed as it continued to throw spears at Yuan from the sky.

Hundreds of spears later, Yuan left the ground and flew into the air as well.

"So you've finally decided to fight me!" The Demon Lord said as it summoned its swords and flew towards him.

Clang!

The two of them clashed in the air, causing the clouds around them to ripple away.

"You fell for it, human!" The Demon Lord suddenly grinned.

The next second, two more arms appeared behind the Demon Lord's back, preparing to strike Yuan at any moment now.

"Let's see if your movement technique works in the air!"

However, Yuan remained calm despite the Demon Lord's surprise.

And right as the Demon Lord moved its arms, Yuan's eyes glowed golden, causing the Demon Lord to halt for a split second.

In this split second, Yuan used the invisible Starry Abyss to create a hole in the Demon Lord's face, taking it by surprise for a second time.

And with his third strike—

"Demon Sealing Strike!"

Yuan used this chance to stab the Empyrean Overlord in the chest.

"He did it!"

The Lan Family watching from afar trembled in excitement after seeing Yuan successfully strike the Demon Lord.

"AAAAAH! DAMN YOU!" The Demon Lord shouted in rage after realizing that Yuan had managed to injure it successfully.

Normally, it wouldn't react even if it had its entire body crushed into meat paste, but a single strike from someone with a demon sealing technique is akin to death no matter how minor the injury! Hell, even an injury as small as a paper cut will seal a demon's fate!

This is why the demons feared the Demon Sealing Clan so much. If they so much as bump into their swords, it would mark the end for the demons.

After his successful strike, Yuan immediately retrieved his sword and distanced himself from the Demon Lord, running back to the Lan Family just in case.

"Fuck! Fuck! Fuck!

The Demon Lord didn't even bother to chase after Yuan and instead began digging a hole in its own stomach with its bare hands, trying to rip away the injury created by Yuan.

But alas, the Demon Lord soon realized that its efforts were in vain since the petrifying effects eventually began to spread throughout its body.

"No! No! No! It can't end here! It can't! I still have to leave this godforsaken world and rule the outside world! I cannot die here!" The Demon Lord began shouting like a maniac who'd gone crazy.

Who could've thought that after struggling for hundreds of thousands of years, the Demon Lord would succumb to a human who, logically speaking, shouldn't even have the qualifications to face it.

Unfortunately for the Demon Lord, Yuan was someone who transcended all logic and common sense even in the cultivation world where almost anything can happen.

"If I die... I will take at least one of you with me!!!" The Demon Lord suddenly flew towards their direction with its eyes bright red and a resolute

expression.

Seeing this, Grandpa Lan suddenly shouted, "Shit! It's planning on blowing itself up! If we're caught in that, we'll be in grave danger!"

"What?! It can do something like that?!" Yuan exclaimed.

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Chapter 343 - Core Detonation

"Is there anything we can do to stop it?" Yuan asked them.

"There is none! I'll try to stop it. The rest of you run away!" Grandpa Lan said, prepared to lay down his own life for them.

However, Yuan said to him, "No! I will take care of it!"

"What?! You'll die!" Lan Yingying said to him.

"That's fine. I won't die forever even if I die. However, that might not be the case for you guys." And without waiting for them to respond, Yuan made his move, flying towards the Demon Lord.

"Wait! Young man!" Grandpa Lan tried to stop him, but alas, Yuan completely ignored him and continued moving forward.

"Hahaha! So you want to die, huh?! This is perfect!" The Demon Lord laughed as its aura grew more volatile and intense.

The Demon Lord was not only getting more powerful, but its body was also glowing redder and redder.

As Yuan got closer to the Demon Lord, he wondered if there was anything he could do, but alas, he could not think of any methods that would save him in this desperate situation.

"Hmph! So what if I die? I'll just respawn! So what if I lose my cultivation base? I'll just cultivate some more! If I become a cripple, it won't be my first time! And it's not like I won't be able to walk or move! I'll still be able to explore this world— whether I'm a cultivator or not!"

Yuan changed direction midway, leading the Demon Lord further away from the Lan Family.

Of course, the Demon Lord was more than happy to chase after Yuan even if it wouldn't be able to kill the Lan Family. In its eyes, he would do the other demons a bigger favor if it killed Yuan, who was a much bigger threat than the Lan Family could ever be.

"Do you really think you can outrun me?!" The Demon Lord laughed as it got closer and closer to Yuan.

Even though Yuan's strength could rival even a Spirit Lord as a Spirit Grandmaster, his flying speed was an entirely different story.

Slowly but surely, the Demon Lord caught up to Yuan, and it was just a matter of time before it blew its entire cultivation up.

Yuan stopped running away once they were far enough from the Lan Family, and there was no point when he knew that he wouldn't outrun the Demon Lord.

"In just a few seconds, I will blow up, and everything within ten thousand meters will disappear with me!" The Demon Lord laughed out loud as it hovered a few meters away from Yuan.

"Go ahead. You'll be the only one dying, anyway." Yuan shrugged in a nonchalant manner, dumbfounding the Demon Lord.

"You're not afraid of dying?" The Demon Lord frowned.

"I won't die."

"Bullshit! You're not immortal! Not even a Spirit King would survive a Core Detonation at this level!" The Demon Lord didn't believe Yuan.

Yuan didn't bother responding to it and calmly stared at the Demon Lord that was almost petrified at this moment.

"Oooh! I can feel it! Power overwhelming my body! Hahaha! It's about time! Die for me, human!" The Demon Lord laughed out loud until it exploded.

It was at this moment Yuan thought about logging off to escape the explosion, but alas...

[You cannot log off during combat]

A second later, the Demon Lord's body suddenly began twisting and turning in a spiraling motion, almost like a black hole had appeared inside its body and was consuming the Demon Lord inside-out.

The Demon Lord's body twisted until it was the size and shape of a small pebble, almost like a glass marble of sorts.

This pebble then glowed brightly before exploding with a massive amount of spiritual energy.

Yuan immediately used the Empyrean Overlord to protect himself by placing it in front of his face. However, the explosion was too large and powerful, and Yuan could feel everything below his chest disappear almost instantly.

"Ah!"

Yuan was overwhelmed with pain, losing consciousness almost immediately.

Meanwhile, the Lan Family could see a bright light in the distance, followed by a strong earthquake a second later.

"Yuan!" Lan Yingying felt her heart being squeezed when she saw this light, and tears quickly flowed from her eyes.

"Alas... This young man actually sacrificed his life for us..." Grandpa Lan sighed, feeling an indescribable feeling in his heart.

Many of the participants in the Mystic Realm were also able to see this bright light in the sky, as it was like a second sun that had suddenly appeared in the world.

The sun created by the Demon Lord remained for a good minute before it finally began to subside.

The Lan Family went to the scene of the explosion in hopes to find Yuan's remains, but alas, they were unable to find him, almost like he'd disappeared from this world.

"As expected, his body has completely disintegrated from the Demon Lord's Core Detonation..." Grandpa Lan sighed.

After all, even he wouldn't survive such a devastating attack, much less a Spirit Grandmaster with a human body.

"Yingying, make sure you take care of that baby... That young man sacrificed his own life so that you two— all of us could live..." Grandma Lan said to her in a grieving tone.

"I understand..." Lan Yingying nodded, still with tears in her eyes.

Meanwhile, about a hundred miles away from where the explosion had occurred, a body that was anything but complete laid on the ground, looking like a corpse that had recently been chewed on by wild animals.

"Heavens... That almost scared me to death..." The voice of a young lady resounded after this disfigured body suddenly dropped from the sky and landed behind her.

"Just what on earth happened to this person? His body looks like it'd just ate an explosion. Was he a victim of that random explosion just now?" The young lady inspected the corpse out of curiosity, not feeling grossed out by the awful sight that would normally make any young lady's stomach churn with disgust.

"Hmm? And why does it feel like I have seen him somewhere before?"

Ding!

[Perfect Regeneration has activated!]

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Chapter 344 - Barely Surviving The Explosion

"W-What?! His body is regenerating?!" The young lady was shocked when the mutilated body suddenly began healing, and she watched as this half-completed body regrow the rest of its body as well as all four limbs in just a matter of moments, almost like she was before an immortal monster or something.

The young lady took a few steps back just in case.

A few moments later, the mutilated body recovered perfectly; it was unlike anything the young lady had seen before.

"Ugh..." Yuan slowly opened his eyes to see the sunlight assaulting his eyes.

"Did I die? Did I respawn outside the Mystic Realm?" Yuan slowly sat up, still recalling the pain he'd felt before losing consciousness.

Once his mind and vision began to stabilize, Yuan looked around his surroundings, and to his surprise, he wasn't outside the Mystic Realm!

"What! Don't tell me I didn't die from that explosion?! This is a miracle!" Yuan quickly stood up with excitement on his face.

Fortunately, he'd managed to protect his head and heart. Although his regenerative abilities are not as exaggerated as the demons', it was pretty close, allowing him to regenerate as long as his head and heart are unharmed.

It was at this moment that Yuan realized he was not alone and there was another presence not far away from him.

"Who's there?" Yuan turned to look at the tree a few meters away from him.

"That voice... Player Yuan?"

The young lady who had hidden behind a tree slowly walked out with her hands up, showing Yuan that she was not a threat to him.

"Y-You're..." Yuan was surprised to see Wang Xiuying there.

After revealing herself, Wang Xiuying stared at Yuan with a somewhat amazed expression on her face.

"What is it?" Yuan decided to ask her, feeling like something was amiss right now.

"Uhh..." Wang Xiuying appeared to hesitate for a moment before pointing at his face.

It was at this moment Yuan realized that his mask was gone and his face was in full display.

'Oh no! The explosion must have removed the mask! Now she knows what I look like!' Yuan cried inwardly.

"D-Don't worry, I won't tell anyone what you look like— I promise!" Wang Xiuying quickly said to him, feeling extremely nervous at this moment, as she was worried that he would kill her because she saw his face.

'Hmm? She doesn't recognize me?' Yuan realized that Wang Xiuying didn't realize who he was even though she saw his face.

Fortunately for Yuan, Wang Xiuying only remembers what he looked like when he was a kid. Even though she has seen him plenty of times as an adult, Yuan looks somewhat different in the real world because of his skinny appearance, and Wang Xiuying hasn't seen him since his recovery. Furthermore, his appearance in cultivation online has been enhanced as a cultivator.

"A-Also... your clothes..." Wang Xiuying pointed at his legs with a blushing face.

Yuan looked down, and to his surprise, he was completely naked from his chest down.

While his body regenerated, his clothes were a different story. No wonder why it felt a little breezy down there.

"Umm... Sorry, but I don't have any clothes on me..." Yuan said in a calm voice.

"I-I'll give you some of mine, okay?" Wang Xiuying said as she removed the first layer of her clothes.

Luckily for them, disciple uniforms in the cultivation world are mostly unisex, so both genders can wear them and look the same.

"Thank you..." Yuan accepted her clothes and quickly wore them.

Although they were a little small, it was good enough to be worn.

"Anyways, what were you doing that made you in such a state? And how on earth are you still alive? I thought you were some kind of immortal monster at first!" Wang Xiuying said to him afterward.

"Oh... I was fighting some really powerful demon, and it decided to blow itself up." Yuan sighed.

"Is that what caused the explosion? You're really something else, Player Yuan. No wonder why you're the number one player in the world right now." Wang Xiuying said.

"What do you plan on doing now?"

"I'm going to go back and see if there's anything left of the demon just in case it also survived," Yuan said.

"Can I come with you? I won't get in your way— I promise. I just want to see how Player Yuan 'plays' the game." She asked him.

"I don't mind." Yuan nodded.

Since he already knew her and was even on good terms with her in the real world, Yuan didn't mind letting her follow him.

"Ah. Do you know which way was the explosion?" Yuan asked her.

"That way."

Yuan nodded his head and proceeded to follow the direction she pointed.

Sometime later, they arrived at the site where the explosion occurred, and as expected, the destruction caused by the Demon Lord wasn't anything to laugh at.

There was a massive crater where the Demon Lord exploded, almost like a meteorite had landed in this place.

"My lord... you survived something like this?" Wang Xiuying turned to look at him with a dazed expression.

"I know... I'm also surprised..." Yuan mumbled.

The crater was a few miles in diameter, and it could be a large lake if it was filled with water.

"I'll be right back," Yuan said to her before flying into the crater to see if he could sense the Demon Lord.

"H-He's flying?! He can fly?! Does this mean he's already a Spirit Grandmaster?! Impossible! We've only been in the Mystic Realm for a week! Even if his cultivation base didn't reset to the beginning like the rest of us, he still shouldn't have been able to reach Spirit Grandmaster in such a short time!" Wang Xiuying was truly shocked to the core after witnessing Yuan's flying ability.

Meanwhile, Yuan flew around the crater with his Divine Sense activated.

"Hmm... I don't see the Demon Lord nor its demon core. Maybe the demon core was destroyed by the explosion? I wouldn't be surprised if it was..."

After spending a couple of minutes in the crater without any results, Yuan returned to Wang Xiuying's side.

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Chapter 345 - Unsuspecting Victims

"Did you find what you were looking for?" Wang Xiuying asked him after he returned.

"No, I didn't. Which is probably a good thing," he said.

"What are you going to do now? Head to the Mystic Pagoda? It's only a day from this place."

"I still have one more place to visit."

Wang Xiuying nodded and followed him.

Sometime later, they arrived at the Abandoned Valley.

The only reason Yuan came to this place was for the Lan Family.

'I hope they're fine... The explosion was extremely powerful, after all...' Yuan sighed inwardly.

It would be dreadful if the Lan Family was also affected by the Demon Lord's explosion.

"Wang... Healer Wang, how long was I knocked out after the explosion?" Yuan turned to ask her.

"Uhh... A couple of minutes?"

"Hmm..."

"What about a white snake? Did you see any white snakes in the sky recently?"

"Yes! I saw a flying white snake sometime before the explosion! It was really mythical!" Wang Xiuying nodded her head in excitement just recalling the flying white snake in the sky.

"Before the explosion? Then they probably haven't left yet..." Yuan wondered where the Lan Family could've gone after he was blown away. Surely, they didn't return to the Divine Forest, right? If they did, he won't be able to return to them since he doesn't know where the place was located.

'Hopefully, they're fine.' Yuan prayed inwardly for their safety.

Sometime later, Yuan turned to look at Wang Xiuying and asked her, "I'm going to head to the Mystic Pagoda now. Do you also want to come with me?"

"I do!" Wang Xiuying quickly nodded, as she wouldn't miss this chance that every other player hoped to have— playing alongside Player Yuan!

Yuan looked in the sky to find the blue star before following the direction.

"Player Yuan, if you don't mind me asking, why did you decide to play Cultivation Online?" Wang Xiuying asked him as they walked.

"Because I want to feel alive," he calmly responded.

"Alive...?" Wang Xiuying raised her eyebrows in a puzzled manner.

"Yes. In the real world, even though I am living, I never felt like I am truly alive— at least that was how I felt before I started playing this game." Yuan said.

"Oooh. I think I get what you mean. I have had a lot of patients who told me the same thing." Wang Xiuying said.

And she continued, "Oh, I am a nurse outside."

Yuan merely smiled.

'I know,' he said inwardly.

"What do you do outside? If it's too personal, you don't have to answer. I know you're skeptical since everyone is trying to learn your identity, but I personally don't care about any of that."

"I don't really do anything outside, unfortunately. I stay at home all day."

"So you're a modern-day hermit?" Wang Xiuying said.

"A what?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"A modern-day hermit. Someone who stays at home and doesn't go outside unless absolutely necessary. There are many people like that nowadays due to how popular gaming has become." Wang Xiuying explained.

"Well, I do it not because I like to. I simply don't have a choice." Yuan sighed.

"You must be living a difficult life, huh." Wang Xiuying looked at Yuan, feeling somewhat nostalgic, almost like she has spoken with him before.

'The way he speaks and the feeling he gives me... It's very similar to Yu Tian... I wonder if this is what he would be like if he wasn't in that condition...' Wang Xiuying noticed some similarities before Yuan and Yu Tian, mostly their atmosphere and speech.

'I wonder what he's doing right now.'

"What about you? Why did you decide to play?" Yuan suddenly asked her.

"I played on a whim since it was very popular, but once I realized how effective and unique medicine is in this world, it became my reason for continuing. I have a dream, you see. A dream to heal someone, and I believe the knowledge to do so is in this world!"

"I know it sounds silly, but I have already incorporated some of the medical practices in this world into our world, and it's working perfectly!"

Wang Xiuying looked up into the skies and mumbled, "This game is so realistic that sometimes I wonder whether this is just a game or actually something more— like another world of sorts."

"Another world, huh? How nice would that be if it was true..." A smile appeared on Yuan's face.

After walking for some time, they encountered a magical beast with a cultivation base around the peak of Spirit Apprentice.

"Uh... You're a Spirit Grandmaster, right?" Wang Xiuying turned to look at him.

While she was also at the peak of Spirit Apprentice, she wasn't exactly an expert in fighting.

"I'll take care of it." Yuan said.

He then used the Starry Abyss and Flying Daggers to take care of the magical beast instantly.

"Wow! How do you do that?" Wang Xiuying expressed her admiration for his technique.

"Hm? It's just a Mortal-grade technique that allows me to control a dagger using my spiritual energy."

"How can such a powerful technique only be Mortal-grade?"

After taking care of the magical beast, they continued walking in the grassland until they reached a small city.

Unfortunately for them, neither of them had money, so they were unable to enter the city that required a small fee.

However, even if they had money, the Mystic Realm uses a different currency, so the currency outside wouldn't have much worth in here.

"I guess we can only walk around the city..." Wang Xiuying sighed.

"Or we can fly over it," Yuan suggested.

"Fly?!" Wang Xiuying's eyes flickered with excitement.

"Let's fly!" she nodded in agreement.

"I'll have to carry you if you don't mind," said Yuan.

"I don't mind."

A moment later, Yuan carried Wang Xiuying in a princess carry before flying into the sky, shocking the guards there.

"Heavens! He was a Spirit Grandmaster?! Did we just kick away a Spirit Grandmaster?! We're dead!" The guards began crying once they realized that they'd screwed up big time.

In their minds, Yuan was probably going straight to the city lord to complain.

Of course, Yuan did the complete opposite, ignoring the city and flying straight over it.

"Wow! So this is what it feels like to fly!" Wang Xiuying looked down at the city with exhilaration.

"I cannot wait until I become a Spirit Grandmaster so that I can fly as well! But that might take a few years!"

Once they were on the other side of the city, Wang Xiuying said, "Player Yuan, do you mind if we continue flying for a little longer? If you're tired, we can go back down, though."

"You can just call me Yuan. And I don't mind. We travel much faster this way as well." Yuan nodded.

Sometime later, Yuan suddenly stopped in midair with his gaze towards the ground.

"There are some people there. I think they're also participants." Yuan said.

Wang Xiuying looked down, and sure enough, there were two people wearing the same uniform at the bottom, and these people hadn't noticed them yet.

"I think that's the Diamond Palms Sect. They're from the Northern Continent and ranked tenth." Wang Xiuying recognized them since they were also on the same continent as her sect.

"What are you going to do?" She then asked.

"Well, my Sect Master told me to get rid of the other participants as soon as I see them," Yuan said.

"G-Get rid of...?" Wang Xiuying's body shivered at his words.

"Yes. If I kill them inside this place, they'll be teleported outside and disqualified." Yuan nodded.

Then he added, "Don't worry, I won't disqualify you."

"Really?" Wang Xiuying released a sigh of relief after hearing that.

"Really."

"Anyways, I don't want them to see my face, so I'll get rid of them from up here."

After taking a deep breath, Yuan retrieved the Starry Abyss and made it turn invisible.

He then used Flying Daggers to control the Starry Abyss, commanding it to fly towards the two unsuspecting victims on the bottom.

A second later, two holes appear in their faces, instantly killing them.

Wang Xiuying swallowed nervously when she saw this.

'He can kill us as easily as breathing, and we won't even know what hit us...' she sighed inwardly.

The difference between them was simply too vast.

Meanwhile, outside the Mystic Pagoda, the Sect Master of the Diamond Palms Sect was shocked to the core when his disciples suddenly died out of the blue.

"What?! What the fuck just happened?! Who killed my disciples?!" He exclaimed, causing the others to look at his disciples that laid on the ground in the Mystic Realm with a large hole in their heads.

"Heavens... How brutal yet efficient..."

A few moments later, the bodies of the two dead participants disappeared from the Mystic Realm before appearing outside with their injury fully recovered.

"Huh? What happened? Why are we outside the Mystic Realm?"

The two didn't even realize that they had been killed even after waking up outside the Mystic Realm. In their eyes, their visions had turned black for a split second, and before they were aware, they were already outside the Mystic Realm. The thought of being killed just now didn't even cross their minds.

It was not until after their Sect Master approached them and told them what happened that they finally realized they had been killed.

"What?! That's impossible! There wasn't even anybody around us!" The two of them exclaimed, looking extremely confused by the situation.

As for Wang Xiuying's view... After meeting Yuan, the mirror suddenly stopped spectating her, almost as though the treasure could no longer find her location.

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Chapter 346 - Who Is Responsible For This?!

"Are you sure you weren't ambushed or something?" The Diamond Palms Sect's Master asked the two disciples that had been brutally killed.

"I'm confident that we were alone, Sect Master!" One of the disciples quickly responded with a serious expression on his face. "We were in open land, and we haven't encountered another participant since we entered!"

"Then how did you two die? Who killed you?" The Sect Master mumbled in a dazed voice.

Even he didn't see what had happened to them through the treasure. Their death was so sudden and random that if he was told his disciples were killed by ghosts, he would probably believe it.

The Sect Master then turned to look at Senior Nie and bowed to him, "Senior Nie, what should we do now? Has something like this happened before? Where the participants die out of nowhere?"

Senior Nie shook his head and said, "No, this has never happened before. As for what happens... Since your participants have died inside the Mystic Realm, regardless of the circumstances, your sect is now disqualified. Whatever points you received before the disqualification will be your final score."

The Sect Master of the Diamond Palms Sect staggered like he was about to faint after hearing Senior Nie's words. How could they be disqualified so early on in the Mystic Realm? They have been in the top ten for over a hundred years! At this rate, it would be a miracle if they manage to even get

into the top 100! How could such a tragedy befall their sect?! Who did they offend to deserve this?!

However, as much as the Sect Master of the Diamond Palms Sect wanted to ask for a second chance, he knew it was pointless, and he'd only be making himself into a laughing stock.

The other Sect Masters swallowed nervously when they saw this, silently praying to themselves that this wouldn't happen to their sect.

But Alas, within the next few hours, many other participants experienced the same tragedy the Diamond Palms Sect had experienced.

The participants were dying left and right without a single person knowing the cause, and this caused a great commotion outside the Mystic Realm.

"Just what in Heaven's name is going on?! Who is responsible for this?!"

"Could it be another participant? Or is someone from the Mystic Realm responsible for this?!"

"This is outrageous! At this rate, the sect ranking for the next 10 years will be all messed up!"

Senior Nie was greatly bewildered by this situation, as he has never seen anything like this before.

"What do you think is happening, Elder Nie?" One of the crystal balls asked him.

"I really don't know what to tell you. Somebody is killing all of these people without showing himself or his methods. It's like he has an invisible weapon or something similar. And at the rate he's killing them, taking into account the distance between each victim, this predator is traveling very quickly— too quickly if I am being honest."

"What does this all mean?" Another voice asked.

After pondering for a moment, Elder Nie said, "This may sound absurd, but if we cannot see this killer from the treasure, he's probably a Mystic Realm native, and for some reason, he's killing every single participant. As for his reason for doing so... We will probably never know..."

"We have known that the natives inside the Mystic Realm aren't very friendly towards us outsiders, but they have never outright hunted the participants until today. Did something change within the Mystic Realm?" One of the voices from the crystal ball spoke.

"What should we do about the sect ranking this year? It's a freaking mess already, and there are still three weeks left. At this rate, all of the participants will be disqualified."

Senior Nie then said, "The cultivation world is volatile in nature. Anything can happen, even ridiculous events that nobody can imagine, and this is simply one of these moments. Even if the sect ranking is flipped around this year, where the previous lowest ranking sect becomes first and the previous first rank becomes last, we will judge it as we usually do."

Meanwhile, at the Dragon Essence Temple, Long Yijun and the other sect elders were clearly very worried about the current situation.

"I wonder what's going on, really. It's been a week since the Mystic Realm started and we still haven't seen Disciple Yuan's shadow, much less the person himself. I hope he's fine." Long Yijun sighed, completely unaware that Yuan was behind this phenomenon.

While he did tell Yuan to disqualify as many participants as he could, Long Yijun could've never expected this kind of outcome.

However, two people there understood what was going on.

"Xiao Hua, these invisible attacks... It's definitely him, right?" Feng Yuxiang turned to ask her.

After a moment of silence, Xiao Hua nodded, "The way all of these people are killed as efficiently as possible with a single strike to the head... It

definitely resembles Brother Yuan's style."

After spending so much time with Yuan, she was obviously used to his fighting style, and Yuan was someone who would always go for the head whenever it was possible. Out of the thousands of magical beasts he has slain, most of them had died from a single strike to the head.

After getting Xiao Hua's confirmation, Feng Yuxiang said to Long Yijun and the others, "I think it's the Young Master behind these attacks."

"What? Yuan? Really? How can you tell?" Elder Xuan quickly asked.

"The attack patterns and these invisible strikes... One of the Young Master's Soul Weapons can turn invisible, and looking at the size of these holes, it matches what his Starry Abyss is capable of." Feng Yuxiang explained to them.

"If that's the case, how come we can't see him? Where is he killing them from?" Elder Shan then asked.

"I have a speculation, but it sounds a little too absurd even for the Young Master..." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Let us hear it." Long Yijun said with a serious expression on his face.

Feng Yuxiang took a deep breath before continuing, "The sky."

"What? Are you saying that Disciple Yuan is somehow killing them from the skies—that he's flying?" Elder Shan looked at her with wide eyes, as it was too unbelievable.

After all, only Spirit Grandmasters could possibly achieve such feats!

Feng Yuxiang sighed, "That's why I didn't want to say it. It sounds absurd, I know, but it's the only thing I can think of."

And she continued, "Think about it—the first two victims were in an empty grassland for miles with nowhere to hide, yet they were killed without

seeing a shadow. If there's nobody around them, then the attack could've only come from one place—the skies."

"I see, that makes sense... but it also doesn't make sense at the same time." Elder Xuan said.

"In order to attack from the sky, Disciple Yuan must have learned to fly, but in order to do so, he must have reached at the very least Spirit Grandmaster. However, it's only been a week since the Mystic Realm opened. Even if Disciple Yuan somehow managed to escape having his cultivation base wiped, he still wouldn't be able to reach Spirit Grandmaster in such a short time—at least he shouldn't."

Feng Yuxiang shrugged, "I don't know. The Young Master is unpredictable. He's literally the reason why I try to avoid using the word 'impossible' since he somehow always makes the impossible... well... possible."

"Let's continue watching. Maybe Disciple Yuan will show up sooner or later." Elder Shan suggested.

Inside the Mystic Realm, Wang Xiuying watched as Yuan disqualified the 39th disciple with a nonchalant expression on her face, almost like she was already used to seeing such a sight.

'At this rate, he'll kill all of the participants in the Mystic Realm before the 30 days time limit is over...' Wang Xiuying sighed inwardly.

The disparity between Yuan and all of the participants was simply too vast.

This made Wang Xiuying wonder why he was being so nice and friendly to her. Normally, someone as secretive as Player Yuan wouldn't reveal so much about himself to a stranger like her, yet he has spoken to her as though they were already friends.

In fact, Wang Xiuying already considers Player Yuan as her friend, something she didn't think was possible before today.

"Congratulations, Yuan." Wang Xiuying suddenly said to him.

"Hm? What for?" He raised his eyebrows slightly in a puzzled manner.

"Congratulations on getting first place for the Mystic Realm, obviously."

"Haha... We don't know that yet. There are still 3 weeks left. Anything can happen in these next three weeks."

"You're so humble, Yuan. Think about it... You're a Spirit Grandmaster who can take out any participant with a single thought. Who in this place could rival someone like you?"

"Perhaps that's the case, but despite my cultivation base, I nearly died today. This shows me that no matter how powerful you are, you are not invincible and you can never be too careful in the cultivation world."

"If you say it like that, I guess so..." Wang Xiuying nodded.

Meanwhile, at the Mystic Pagoda, three figures stood before a tall building that emitted a majesty aura.

"What are we doing here, grandfather?" Lan Yingying asked him.

"I just felt like coming here, that's all..." Grandpa Lan responded with a gloomy feeling around him.

After standing there silently for a few minutes, Grandpa Lan clasped his hands together and bowed to the Mystic Pagoda.

"I'm sure it was fate that he came to this place. Thank you for guiding that young man here, Lord. If only I was a little bit stronger..."

Chapter 347 - Mystic Pagoda

Lan Yingying and Grandma Lan followed Grandpa Lan's movements, bowing to the Mystic Pagoda with respect.

Sometime later, Grandpa Lan transformed into his beast form and carried his family back to the Divine Forest.

Meanwhile, somewhere in the Mystic Realm, Gao Dongya and Xue Jiye finally began their journey after spending an entire week increasing their cultivation, reaching the Spirit Warrior realm.

"The spiritual energy in this world is abundant and rich. If only the outside world was like this, I would've become a Spirit Master by now!" Xue Jiye sighed out loud.

Then she turned to look at Gao Dongya and asked him, "What should we do now? We still have no idea where Disciple Yuan is."

"It would only be a waste of time if we look for him when we don't even know where we are, much less where he is. The only thing we can do right now is follow the plan and obtain as many points as we can with what little time we have left." Gao Dongya said.

And he continued, "Hopefully, that's what he's doing as well."

"What do you want to do then? Hunt for magical beasts for the next three weeks?" Xue Jiye suggested, as that seemed to be the most efficient method of grinding points.

Gao Dongya narrowed his eyes at her and said, "What a simple woman. Do you really believe you are the only one with that thought? We won't achieve first place if we do something like this!"

"Stop calling me woman! I have a name— Xue Jiye! And do you really think we can take first place with just the three— two of us? Your ambition is too high!"

"I don't know about you but I always strive for the best results, and the best result for the Mystic Realm would be the Mystic Pagoda!" Gao Dongya said in a calm voice.

"The Mystic Pagoda? Hmph! Nobody has opened that place up since ancient times. What makes you think you'll be able to open it?"

"If I had your attitude, I would never be able to open it." Gao Dongya said, and he turned around and began walking.

"Enough chit-chatting. We have already spent too much time increasing our cultivation."

"Since you're so smart, why don't you tell me where we can find the Mystic Pagoda?" Xue Jiye said.

Gao Dongya then pointed to the skies, where a blue star flickered.

"If you'd done your research before coming here, you would know that by following the blue star, you'll reach the Mystic Pagoda. This isn't the first time people have been to this place. Seriously, why did the Sect Master even pick someone like you to come here if you're not taking this seriously?"

"Che." Xue Jiye sucked her teeth at Gao Dongya's response that left her speechless.

Thus, they began their journey towards the Mystic Pagoda, as was every other participant in the Mystic Realm.

Normally, they would be hunting magical beasts and doing whatever they can to increase their points, but this year was different, as everybody wanted to ascend to the Spirit Heaven, where their career as a cultivator would surely reach a new level.

Even if their sects were to receive a lower rank because of this, none of the participants cared.

In their mind, since there was someone as monstrous as Yuan participating in the Mystic Realm, the only way they could beat someone like him was to go above and beyond and open up the Mystic Pagoda.

"Looks like all of the participants are heading towards the Mystic Pagoda."

The observers outside the Mystic Realm noticed this.

"This year's Mystic Realm is truly a mess. Not only are the participants getting killed by a mysterious force, but they're also not following the routine. This is all because of Senior Nie's presence." One of the Sect Masters there sighed.

"Can you really blame them, though? If I was in their shoes, I would also be trying to do whatever I can to go to the Spirit Heaven."

"If I weren't so old and have an entire sect to take care of, I would also love to try to ascend."

While the Sect Masters mumbled to each other, Senior Nie and the people in the Spirit Heavens spoke to each other.

"Do you think the Mystic Pagoda will finally open this year?" One of the crystal balls asked.

"Most likely not," said another voice.

"Yeah, I highly doubt it as well."

"The Mystic Realm has existed for countless years with countless challengers, yet not a single person has managed to open the Mystic Pagoda. This year won't be any different."

However, Senior Nie smiled and said, "Actually, there is one person who'd managed to open the Mystic Pagoda."

"Hm? There was someone like that? How come I have never heard of it?"

Half of the spectators were hearing this for the first time.

"Are you talking about the owner of the Mystic Realm, Elder Nie?"

"Wait a second... The Mystic Realm has an owner? This is my first time hearing about this!"

Senior Nie nodded his head and said, "It's not surprising some of you don't know about this since it's only mentioned in ancient scrolls regarding the Mystic Realm."

"Countless years ago, when the Mystic Realm still had no Master, people could enter and leave the place at will. However, all of that changed when a certain individual—a certain young man entered the Mystic Realm and became its Master."

"W-Wait a moment..." One of the voices interrupted and spoke, "You're telling me some youngster became the Master of the Mystic Realm? How did that happen? Who is this young man?"

"Nobody knows his identity." Senior Nie said.

"What? Nobody? How is that possible?" A voice of disbelief quickly resounded.

"Because he was always wearing a mask. The only thing we know about this individual is that he's a young man—at least that's what people got from his voice. He entered the Mystic Realm, became its Master, left the place, and he was never heard from again."

"Of course, this person also made new rules for the Mystic Realm and closed its doors. Now, only those with tokens are allowed to go inside."

Then someone asked, "What about the tokens? Where did we get them?"

"It was given to the founders of our sect, and we have been hosting the Mystic Realm ever since then. Nobody besides the founders knows why

we're doing this, but it's become a tradition of sorts, and nobody really questions it anymore." Senior Nie said to them.

"Heavens... And here I thought we were doing this because we're recruiting potential talents for our sect..." One of the voices mumbled in a dazed voice.

"Honestly, that's how most of us see this nowadays, so regardless of what our founders were thinking, this is the outcome," said another voice.

Meanwhile, inside the Mystic Realm, Wang Xiuying suddenly pointed to the tall building at the end of the horizon and said, "Look at that pagoda! I think that's the Mystic Pagoda!"

Yuan nodded and sped up a little, quickly approaching the pagoda in the distance.

Sometime later, they arrived at the pagoda, and Yuan descended from the sky.

"We got here much quicker than expected since we flew here. Look at the door, this is definitely the Mystic Pagoda." Wang Xiuying pointed at the top of the door, where the words 'Mystic Pagoda' were engraved.

"This place looks more 'ordinary' than I'd anticipated," Yuan said as he looked at the Mystic Pagoda.

"You think so too?" Wang Xiuying agreed with him, and she continued, "I thought it would be more special, but I have seen similar buildings in the Northern Continent plenty of times by now. However, this place does give me a unique feeling that other places don't, but I cannot pinpoint what this feeling is exactly."

"Let's take a look around the place!" Wang Xiuying suggested.

The two of them proceeded to walk around the Mystic Pagoda to see if there was anything around the place.

Literally, a minute later, they returned to the front of the place.

"I didn't see anything special. What about you?"

Yuan shook his head. Even with Divine Sense, he wasn't able to see anything unique.

Of course, his Divine Sense wasn't able to penetrate the Mystic Pagoda for some reason, almost like there was something protecting it.

A few moments later, Wang Xiuying suddenly approached the doors to the Mystic Pagoda and tried to open it.

However, she quickly realized that was impossible, as there was no door handle at the door.

Thus, she could only try knocking on the door.

"Hello? Anybody inside?"

"..."

Nobody responded to her, something Wang Xiuying had expected even before knocking on the door.

"Any idea how to open this place?" Wang Xiuying turned to look at Yuan, who had been standing there in silence, staring at the Mystic Pagoda with a dazed expression on his face.

"Yuan? Are you okay?" she asked him again.

"Y-Yes..." Yuan nodded, and he continued, "This place seems so nostalgic for some reason, almost like I have been here before."

"You're thinking too much. There's obviously no way you could've been here before." Wang Xiuying chuckled.

"I guess..." Yuan nodded and approached Wang Xiuying before standing at the door to the Mystic Pagoda.

It was at this moment the doors that had been sealed shut for countless years suddenly began to tremble.

"T-This is..." Wang Xiuying's eyes widened with shock when the doors suddenly opened. Why did the doors suddenly open? They didn't even do anything special!

"M-Maybe it opened because I knocked on the doors?" she mumbled, as this was the only explanation she could think of.

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Chapter 348 - Suspiciously Easy

"The Mystic Pagoda opened? Why?" Yuan raised his eyebrows upon seeing the doors open automatically.

However, there was nobody to welcome them inside, so why did the doors open?

"Let's go inside and check it out," Yuan suggested.

"W-Wait!" Wang Xiuying turned around, grabbed him, and quickly pulled him away from the Mystic Pagoda.

Once they were far enough, the doors to the Mystic Pagoda closed again.

"Don't be so hasty, Yuan! What if it's a trap? If you ask me, I think it's too easy! There's no way the Mystic Pagoda would open so easily for us when nobody has managed to open it for so long!" Wang Xiuying explained to him why they shouldn't go inside.

Yuan nodded after hearing her words, "That makes sense. It's quite suspicious how the place just opened."

"That's right! What if we're ambushed by traps the moment we go inside? That would be disastrous!" Wang Xiuying said.

"Then what should we do?" Yuan asked her.

"I say we wait until someone else goes inside and see what happens. I'm sure there are people coming to this place as we speak." Wang Xiuying responded.

"Okay. We can observe them from the skies, where we should be safe."
Yuan agreed.

"What should we do in the meantime?"

"I don't know. It's getting a bit late, so I'm about to log off for the day."

"It's also almost time for dinner for me as well."

Thus, the two of them looked around the Mystic Pagoda for a few more minutes before logging off.

In the real world, Yuan said to Meixiu, "I have arrived at the Mystic Pagoda."

"Really? Were you able to open it?" Meixiu asked him as she fed him dinner.

"About that... The Mystic Pagoda opened by itself, but it might be a trap, so we didn't go inside."

"Wait... We? You're with somebody?" Meixiu raised her eyebrows.

"That's right. I'm with Wang Xiuying right now. I met her by chance, and we've been traveling together since then."

"I see..." Meixiu mumbled.

"By the way, are you responsible for killing the participants? A lot of participants had been disqualified after being killed by an invisible attack." Meixiu told him about the chaos that occurred outside the Mystic Realm because of his actions.

"Oh, yeah, that was me. I took care of everyone as we approached the Mystic Pagoda. There were a lot of them, but I made sure to kill all of them like the Sect Master had advised us to do."

"So Feng Feng and Xiao Hua were right about you being responsible for the attacks..."

"All of the participants were unharmed after they left the Mystic Realm, right?" Yuan asked her.

The only reason he could kill them so casually was because he was told that they wouldn't die inside the Mystic Realm.

"Yes, all of them were fine. However... A few of them had lost a couple of levels for their cultivation after being killed." Meixiu revealed this to him.

"Well, at least they're not hurt." Yuan casually said.

In his mind, it was much better to lose their cultivation than to die since cultivation can be restored through time whilst death was permanent— for the NPCs at the very least.

Meixiu also didn't think too much of it since she was not a cultivator.

"Will you be playing tonight?" Meixiu asked him after dinner.

"Yes, I will."

"Okay."

Sometime later, Yuan returned to the game whilst Meixiu went to sleep.

Inside the game, Yuan flew towards the sky and began overseeing the Mystic Pagoda, patiently waiting for someone to fall for this 'trap'.

Once he realized that it might take a while before someone shows up, he decided to start practicing his flying skill in the sky.

Thus, Yuan proceeded to spend the entire night circling around the place, improving his flying speed and air maneuvers.

Wang Xiuying returned to the game in the morning.

"Welcome back." Yuan greeted her.

"Yuan? When did you come back on?" she asked him.

"Since last night."

"What? You spent the entire night playing? That's not healthy, you know." Wang Xiuying sort of lectured him.

Then she asked, "Did anybody come through at all?"

"No, I didn't see anybody."

"It might take a couple of days before someone—"

"Wait. I sense a presence not far from here." Yuan suddenly interrupted her.

"Really? Then let's hide!" Wang Xiuying said.

Yuan nodded and carried her into the air, hiding inside the clouds.

About fifteen minutes later, a figure approached the Mystic Pagoda.

"Hm? That person looks familiar for some reason..." Yuan narrowed his eyes at this young man that had a goofy-looking face.

After pondering for a moment, he remembered where he'd seen this person.

"Ah, that's the player who wanted me to show my face to him."

"He's a player?" Wang Xiuying asked.

"Yes."

The two of them continued to watch this player's every movement.

The player first looked around the Mystic Pagoda just like they did when they first arrived. Once he found nothing special, the player stood before the door and started knocking on it.

However, there was no response from the Mystic Pagoda.

"What's happening? Why isn't the door opening for him?" Wang Xiuying mumbled in a puzzled voice.

"Let's wait a little bit longer," Yuan suggested.

A few minutes later, the player started kicking the door to the Mystic Pagoda, hoping to open it by force.

Once the player realized that kicking the door wasn't doing him any good, he started hitting it with the ordinary sword in his grasp.

Ding!

The sword rebounded after striking the door, flying right out of the player's grasp.

After retrieving the sword, the player tried hitting the door again multiple times.

However, in the end, the Mystic Pagoda remained unharmed.

"It doesn't look like the Mystic Pagoda will open for him." Wang Xiuying said.

"Then there's no reason to keep him alive," Yuan said, immediately controlling the Starry Abyss to fly at the goofy-looking player, creating a hole in his face a second later.

Chapter 349 - Inside The Mystic Pagoda

Once the player's corpse disappeared from the Mystic Realm, Yuan returned to the ground with Wang Xiuying.

"The door didn't open for that player. How weird." Wang Xiuying went to knock on the door again a few moments later, but there was no response this time.

"It's not opening even for us now. I wonder how this place works," she sighed.

Yuan didn't say anything and approached her.

"Eh?! It opened again!" Wang Xiuying was surprised when the door suddenly opened.

She then turned to look at Yuan with a pondering expression on her face.

"Yuan, can you go over there for a second?" Wang Xiuying pointed.

Yuan nodded and walked to the location.

And just as Wang Xiuying expected, the Mystic Pagoda closed its doors when Yuan distanced himself from the building.

"Yuan! I think the door is opening for you! Come back here!" Wang Xiuying said to him.

"For me? Why?" Yuan raised his eyebrows in a puzzled manner.

Once he approached the Mystic Pagoda, the doors opened again.

"Look! The door opened when you got close! And it will close if you walk away!" Wang Xiuying said.

And she continued, "Do you know why this is happening? Did you do anything special before coming here?"

Yuan shook his head, "Not that I remember."

Besides fighting some demons and meeting the Lan Family, he didn't really do anything special.

'Hmm? Wait a second. If the Emyrean Overlord belonged to the Lord, perhaps the Mystic Pagoda recognizes it, hence why it's opening its doors for me?' Yuan suddenly recalled this fact.

"I'm going to go inside then," Yuan said a moment later.

"I will come with you!" Wang Xiuying quickly said.

Although there might be traps inside, it was much better than staying out here by herself, especially when there might be many participants who will be arriving soon. In other words, she felt much safer by Yuan's side.

Yuan nodded his head, and the two of them entered the pagoda a moment later.

"This place is... empty..." Wang Xiuying said as she looked around the room that had literally nothing but a spiraling staircase a few meters away.

After looking around to make sure the room was really empty, they proceeded upstairs to the second floor.

However, the second floor was also empty.

"Nothing here either? Where are the treasures? A place this difficult to get into should have at least a couple of heaven-defying treasures, right?" Wang Xiuying sighed.

And just like previously, after spending a few minutes looking around, they proceeded to the next floor.

"From its appearance outside, the Mystic Pagoda should have nine floors." Wang Xiuying said as they entered the third floor.

"Why am I not surprised?" Wang Xiuying merely shook her head in disappointment when she saw that nothing was on the third floor as well.

However, they still looked around regardless.

Sometime later, they reached the eighth floor, and as expected, it was empty.

"There's only one more floor. I hope there's something there." Wang Xiuying said after looking around the place.

After taking a deep breath, they walked upstairs.

"Look! There's actually something here!" Wang Xiuying spoke with excitement when she noticed something different about the room.

However, when she realized what these things were, her excitement immediately died.

"A bed... a desk... a chair... That's it?" Wang Xiuying sighed.

Then she noticed the mask hanging on the wall behind the desk.

"Well, that's something unique, I guess."

Yuan looked around and said, "Well, I was told the Master of the Mystic Realm used to live here, so it makes sense this room looks like this."

He then turned to look at the mask on the wall and mumbled, "That must be the mask he wore. What an ordinary-looking mask."

Compared to his Black Jade Mask, the mask on the wall looked too ordinary. In fact, it was just an ordinary mask with nothing special about it.

"I was hoping for this mask to be a treasure, but it turned out to be ordinary as well." Wang Xiuying said after inspecting the mask.

"Here." She then handed it to Yuan.

"Your old mask broke, right? You can use this one instead."

"Thank you." Yuan accepted the mask and immediately put it back on his face.

Coincidentally, the mask fitted his face perfectly.

"What should we do now? There's clearly nothing in this room besides the furniture." Wang Xiuying said.

Yuan looked around, and he noticed that there was another staircase leading up.

"There's still one more floor," he said to her.

"What? How is that possible? I remember very clearly that there are only nine floors in this place! At least that's what it looked like from the outside!"

"I also counted nine floors." Yuan agreed with her.

"Maybe it's a secret floor where the treasures are held?" Wang Xiuying's eyes began flickering with excitement and hope again.

"Let's check it out."

A few moments later, they climbed the staircase.

The tenth floor was clearly much smaller than the other floors, almost like an attic or sorts.

However, there was nothing on this floor as well— nothing physical at the very least.

"What do you think this drawing is?" Yuan asked her as he looked at the complicated drawing on the floor.

"This looks like a magic circle... At least that's what they look like in movies." Wang Xiuying said.

And she continued, "But this is the cultivation world, so it's probably a formation. I have seen a couple of them before, but none of them look even remotely as complicated as this one."

"I think this is what is protecting the Mystic Pagoda." Wang Xiuying said after pondering for a moment.

"I think so too." Yuan agreed.

However, just as they prepared to go back downstairs, the formation suddenly began to glow brightly.

"W-What's happening?!" Wang Xiuying exclaimed, and she subconsciously hugged Yuan.

"I have no idea—"

Before he could even finish his sentence, the two of them disappeared from the room, almost like they had been teleported or something.

Chapter 350 - Pillar Of Light

Once Yuan and Wang Xiuying disappeared from the tenth floor in the Mystic Pagoda, the building itself began to glow a bright azure-colored light before shooting a massive beam into the sky for everyone in the Mystic Realm to see.

At the Divine Forest, Lan Yingying was floating on top of the water at the waterfall where Yuan impregnated her with a dazed expression on her face when she first noticed the azure-colored pillar of light in the distance that pierced the heavens.

"W-What is that?"

For some reason, Lan Yingying felt an urge to approach that light.

A few moments later, her grandparents could be seen flying in her direction in the sky.

"Grandfather! What is going on?" She asked him.

"I also have no idea, but it seems to be coming from the Mystic Pagoda! Something must have happened there! We must see what's happening!" Grandpa Lan said to her in an urgent manner.

Lan Yingying quickly left the water to put on her clothes.

A few moments later, Grandpa Lan transformed into his beast form before carrying the other two into the skies, flying towards the direction of the beam.

Meanwhile, outside the Mystic Realm, the spectators were shocked when they saw this azure-colored beam in the sky.

However, they were not shocked because of the light itself. They were shocked because the pillar of light had somehow managed to penetrate the Mystic Realm and appear in their world, piercing their heavens as well!

"Heavens! What is happening this time?!"

The voices from the crystal balls were greatly shocked by this phenomenon.

"This is also my first time seeing this... I have no idea what is going on..." Senior Nie shook his head with a nervous frown on his face.

There have been too many unexplainable events happening in the Mystic Realm this year. Just what on earth is happening?

"Wait a second... This feeling I am getting from that pillar of light... It's a transportation formation? It's something similar to when I came down to the Lower Heavens from the Spirit Heavens!" Senior Nie suddenly realized this.

"What does that mean?" One of the voices asked.

"Either somebody is going inside the Mystic Realm through a formation or the other way around— someone is leaving the Mystic Realm!" Senior Nie said.

"That's..."

The spectators were speechless. Who could be doing such a thing? And for what reason?

Sometime later, one of the crystal balls cried out loud, "Ah! I can also see the pillar of light here!"

"What?!" Senior Nie exclaimed.

Another voice followed, "It's true! I can see it as well! Look outside!"

The people living at Spirit Heavens immediately looked outside their window, and to their surprise, the pillar of light had somehow managed to

appear in the Spirit Heavens as well.

"Heavens! Don't tell me this is the same pillar of light from the Mystic Realm?"

"What else could it be?! How did this happen?!"

The people from the Spirit Heavens were greatly bewildered by this unknown pillar of light, especially the people that had no idea about what was happening in the Mystic Realm.

The powerful backgrounds from the Spirit Heavens were also alerted by this pillar of light, and people from all over the world were immediately sent to investigate it.

Meanwhile, after disappearing from the Mystic Pagoda, Yuan and Wang Xiuying found themselves on this small platform that was surrounded by clouds, almost like they were somewhere in the sky.

There was a path made from the same material as the platform in front of them, and at the end of this path was a tall wall that resembled city walls.

"Where are we?" Wang Xiuying asked while she was still hugging Yuan's body tightly.

Ding!

[You have discovered Ancient Dragon City]

[Fame +1,000]

"Ancient Dragon City...? Were we teleported to this place by that formation? Just what is this place?" Yuan mumbled in a dazed voice.

However, Yuan was quickly snapped out of his daze when he heard a shouting voice resound in his ears.

"Who are you people?! How did you activate the teleport formation?!"

Before Yuan could even react, a dozen people with weapons in their grasp surrounded him and Wang Xiuying, and they were all emitting the power of a Spirit Grandmaster!

"Y-Yuan..." Wang Xiuying's grasp on him tightened even more after feeling their unfriendly atmosphere.

"Hello, I'm sorry if we're not supposed to be here, but we were brought to this place against our will by accident through a formation... I think." Yuan said to them.

"Impossible! Nobody has used this teleport formation for hundreds of thousands of years!" One of the figures said.

"What is your purpose for coming here?!" Another one asked.

"I already told you guys— I don't know how we got here. We also don't have any reason to be here, so I'd appreciate it if you tell us how we can go back." Yuan said to them.

The group of people turned to look at each other.

After a moment of silence, one of them said, "That's impossible. We also don't know how to activate that formation."

"What?! We can't go back?! What about the Mystic Realm?!" Wang Xiuying exclaimed.

"Mystic Realm...? Don't tell me you're from the Lower Heavens..." One of them recognized the Mystic Realm and asked.

"That's right. We came from the Lower Heavens." Yuan confirmed.

After another moment of silence, the one leading them spoke, "Regardless of your situation, we are going to bring you in for further questioning. If you resist, we'll kill you right here."

In their eyes, neither Wang Xiuying and Yuan were powerful enough to threaten them— especially not Wang Xiuying, who was a mere Spirit

Apprentice, so they lowered their guard a little bit.

"There's nothing we can do now but listen to them, Yuan." Wang Xiuying said to him.

Yuan nodded, "Okay, we'll cooperate."

Thus, the group of Spirit Grandmasters began escorting Yuan and Wang Xiuying towards the city walls in the distance.

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Chapter 351 - Detained

Once they reached the gates, the Spirit Grandmasters stopped Yuan and Wang Xiuying and said to them, "Before you enter, you must wear these."

"Handcuffs...? Really? Why are we being treated like criminals?" Wang Xiuying frowned at the sight of these cuffs.

"Why? Because you guys broke the rules, so you're criminals in our eyes." One of them said.

"What?! What rules did we break? We just got here!" Wang Xiuying was in disbelief.

"Just by coming here without permission, you've broken one of our most sacred rules!"

"But we arrived here by accident! We didn't come here because we wanted to!"

"Regardless of your circumstances or situation, it's a fact that you've stepped onto our sacred soil without permission. Furthermore, you're humans! Humans are not allowed in this place!"

"You're humans as well!" Wang Xiuying refuted.

The Spirit Grandmasters looked at each other before bursting out with laughter.

"Humans? Us? Hahaha! We only took the appearance of humans because it's more convenient to travel in such a small form!"

"That's right! We also take up much less space in this form!"

"T-This form?" Wang Xiuying stared at them with wide eyes, finally realizing the situation.

"Don't tell me you're all magical beasts in human forms? I have heard about it, but this is my first time actually seeing it in person..." Wang Xiuying's body trembled once she realized that they were not really humans, only monsters in human skin.

"That's right! We're all dragons!"

They all held a prideful expression on their faces at this moment.

"D-Dragons?! You're all Divine Beasts?!" Yuan looked at them with surprise.

"What? Not all dragons are Divine Beasts! What an ignorant human." The dragons shook their heads at him.

"Anyways, enough chit-chatting. Hurry up and put on these handcuffs, or we'll consider this is resisting us and we'll kill you on the spot."

"..."

Since they were outnumbered and were technically in the wrong for coming to this place without permission, Yuan and Wang Xiuying agreed to be cuffed without much fuss.

"Good. Now we can enter the city."

Wang Xiuying looked at these cuffs with a frown on her face, and she spoke, "Yuan... I don't feel so good. It's like these cuffs are draining my strength..."

"Eh? Really?" Yuan raised his eyebrows since he didn't feel such effects.

"These are special cuffs that will seal the cultivation of anyone wearing them— mostly humans. As long as you wear these, you won't be able to use your cultivation and cause any troubles."

"As if we'd cause any trouble!" Wang Xiuying exclaimed.

"It's better to be safe than sorry, and we only have these kinds of shackles in this place so it's not like we have a choice."

The dragons said to them before bringing them into the city.

Once they were inside the city, the dragons brought Yuan and Wang Xiuying into this building before tossing them into a jail cell.

"The two of you will stay right there until our supervisor comes for questioning," said the dragons before leaving them alone.

"I can't believe it... To think we'd become criminals and even tossed into a jail cell..." Wang Xiuying sighed, as this was a completely new experience for her.

"We'll be fine as long as we cooperate with them," Yuan said to her.

"This is all that damned Mystic Pagoda's fault! Why did it bring us here?! Are we still inside the Mystic Realm? If not, does this mean we have failed the event since we technically left the place? Aaaah! I have so many questions!" Wang Xiuying sighed out loud.

"There's nothing we can really do since we're already in this place. Once they let us go, we will find a way back home." Yuan said.

"You're really optimistic, huh? What makes you think they'll release us? What if they keep us here forever?"

"But we didn't do anything wrong. Why would they keep us here forever?" Yuan tilted his head with an innocent expression on his face.

"You really don't understand, huh. These people are not human, Yuan! They're all magical beasts! I wouldn't be surprised if they treat humans like trash! Even worse— food!" Wang Xiuying shuddered at the thought of being eaten by dragons.

"If anything happens, we can simply log off," Yuan said.

"But we won't be able to log back on afterward since they'll be waiting for us! In other words, we won't be able to play until we have other players rescue us! But who could possibly rescue us when we don't even know where we are? If the only way to come here is through the Mystic Pagoda, nobody will be able to come here!" Wang Xiuying sighed.

Yuan frowned upon realizing how grave their situation was.

"If we die, maybe we'll respawn outside the Mystic Realm..." Yuan then said.

"I doubt it. Did you already forget? We're inside a city, Yuan. All cities are checkpoints, so if you die, you'll simply respawn in your last city visited." Wang Xiuying said.

"Oh, I didn't know that since I have never died before. And I don't really interact with other players either." Yuan said.

"Anyways, we're in big trouble right now. Hopefully, these dragons don't have any grudges with humans..." Wang Xiuying sighed.

About half an hour later, a figure finally entered their room and stood before their jail cell.

"Hello." Yuan greeted this middle-aged man wearing silver armor that had a dragon design on his chest and two dragon heads on his shoulders.

"Hmmm..." This middle-aged man didn't respond to his greetings, merely staring at them with a solemn expression on his face.

"How long has it been since I last saw humans? Ten thousand years? A hundred thousand years? I don't remember. However, the stench you humans give off... I will never forget it." The middle-aged man mumbled with a look of disdain on his face.

Wang Xiuying swallowed nervously after hearing his words. Clearly, this guy doesn't like humans. Which meant their chances of surviving this nonsense just dropped significantly.

After a moment of silence, the middle-aged man spoke, "I will now ask you questions. If anything that comes out of your mouth is not related to the question, I will have you both executed. Do you understand?"

"Y-Yes..." Wang Xiuying quickly nodded.

Yuan nodded silently.

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Chapter 352 - Interrogation

Once Yuan and Wang Xiuying nodded their heads, the middle-aged man began to speak, "First question— how did you two use the teleport formation to get here?"

"We don't know." Wang Xiuying said, and she continued, "We were standing on this formation, and before we knew it, we were already teleported to this place."

After a moment of silence, the middle-aged man continued, "Second question— where were you guys before this? Where is this formation that you spoke of?"

"It was inside this building that is also within this place called the Mystic Realm."

"The Mystic Realm?" The middle-aged man frowned and turned silent again.

"Third question, what is your purpose for coming here?"

"As we'd already said countless times by now, we didn't come here by choice. We have no reason to be here." Yuan said.

"Last question... What are your backgrounds?" The middle-aged man narrowed his eyes and stared at them with a sharp gaze.

"We're just disciples within the Lower Heavens. We were participating in this event that required us to enter the Mystic Realm, and after exploring the place, we ended up here." Wang Xiuying said.

Sometime later, the middle-aged man turned around and prepared to leave the room.

"W-Wait! What about us?" Wang Xiuying asked him in a nervous voice.

"You'll be staying here for a little longer while I verify some information. Don't worry, as much as I hate you, humans, I don't kill unnecessarily." The middle-aged man said to them before leaving the room.

"Phew... At least they won't immediately kill us..." Wang Xiuying released a relieved sigh.

Thus, the two of them continued to wait inside the jail cell.

Meanwhile, outside the building, the middle-aged man made his way to this massive palace, which took him about an hour of flying.

"Captain Cheng."

The guards at the bottom of this palace greeted this middle-aged man wearing silver armor.

"I'm here to see the Royal Family regarding the teleport formation that had recently been activated," he said.

"The Royal Family is already expecting you."

Captain Cheng nodded his head and proceeded to walk the steps to the palace on the top.

Even though he could simply fly up there, he didn't dare to do so since it was a sign of disregard and disrespect for the royal family that lived in this place.

Sometime later, Captain Cheng entered the palace that was made entirely out of some sort of white jade-like material, giving the place an exquisite atmosphere.

Once inside, Captain Cheng went straight to the audience hall, where four people sat at the end of the room, almost like they were expecting Captain Cheng to arrive.

"This subordinate apologizes for making the Royal Family wait." Captain Cheng knelt on one of his knees and lowered his head before these four people before speaking in a respectful voice.

"Raise your head." One of the four figures spoke.

"Yes, Your Majesty."

Captain Cheng raised his head to look at the four people sitting on the platform before him.

A middle-aged man with sharp facial expressions, a beautiful middle-aged woman that gave off a sophisticated aura, a handsome young man with a stern look on his face, and finally, a graceful young lady with bright and clear eyes.

"Now, tell us about the individuals who'd managed to activate the teleport formation," said the middle-aged man wearing majestic robes fitting of an emperor.

"Yes, Your Majesty." Captain Cheng responded before continuing, "According to my investigation, these two individuals are humans from the Lower Heavens, and they'd accidentally arrived at this place."

"What? Humans from the Lower Heavens? And they accidentally arrived at this place? How is that possible? One doesn't simply just 'accidentally arrive' at our Ancient Dragon City that has been isolated from the rest of the world for millions of years!" The middle-aged woman spoke with a dumbfounded look on her beautiful face.

"They also mentioned coming from the Mystic Realm..." Captain Cheng suddenly added.

"What? The Mystic Realm? Why didn't you say that first, you idiot!" The middle-aged lady quickly said.

"The Mystic Realm... So it's time, huh..." The middle-aged man mumbled with a nostalgic look on his face. "But why are there two people? I was only expecting one."

"Captain Cheng, I want you to bring these two humans here." The middle-aged man then said.

"Pardon me? Your Majesty wants me to bring the humans... here? To the Dragon Palace?" Captain Cheng looked at them with wide eyes filled with shock, as he thought humans are forbidden to step foot inside the Dragon Palace!

"Do I have to repeat myself, Captain Cheng?" The middle-aged man frowned.

"N-No! This subordinate will immediately bring them here! Please excuse me!"

Captain Cheng quickly stood up and left the palace. However, he didn't forget to bow to them once more before leaving.

"Why are you allowing humans to step foot inside our sacred Dragon Palace, father?" The young man sitting beside him asked after Captain Cheng left the scene.

"This is a complicated situation that even I don't understand fully, and it's also our ancestors' will."

"What?! The ancestors?!" The young man and young lady expressed great shock after hearing this.

"You're still too young to learn it, so I will spare the explanation for now. You'll probably understand it sooner or later regardless now that these visitors have finally come." The middle-aged man said.

"Finally come?" The young man raised his eyebrows, as it sounded like they have been waiting for these people to come for a long time now.

Didn't these humans come here by accident? How could they possibly predict something like this?

"I wonder what kind of people these humans are. This will be my first time seeing humans." The young lady suddenly spoke with anticipation in her eyes.

"Why are you excited? They are only humans— inferior beings compared to us dragons. From what I heard, they're all weak and have terrible characteristics. In fact, humans are the reason we've isolated ourselves in this world." The young man sneered.

"Still, I want to see them for myself." The young lady said.

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Chapter 353 - Dragon Palace

After leaving the Dragon Palace, Captain Cheng returned to the building where Yuan and Wang Xiuying were being held.

"Are the humans still inside?" Captain Cheng asked the guards standing outside.

"Yes, Captain! Nobody has entered or left this place ever since you left!" The guards responded.

"Good."

Captain Cheng went inside a moment later to see Yuan and Wang Xiuying sitting in their jail cell with bored-looking expressions on their faces.

"Guards! Open the cells!" Captain Cheng said to them.

"Yes, Captain!" The guards didn't question him and immediately opened the cell doors.

"Are we free?!" Wang Xiuying's face immediately brightened.

"No, you're not free. You're coming with me now." Captain Cheng said to them.

"Oh..." Wang Xiuying sighed after hearing this and returned to look dispirited.

Once they were outside, Captain Cheng carried the two of them into the skies using Qi Manipulation.

"You're... a Spirit King?" Yuan recognized his spiritual energy. However, it was much more powerful than Senior Nie's and even Xiao Hua's cultivation. If he had to take a guess, this person was around the peak of Spirit King.

Captain Cheng looked at Yuan and said, "You can tell? Not bad for someone only in the Spirit Grandmaster realm."

"Only?" Wang Xiuying raised her eyebrows. "How powerful are the people here when you make it sound like Spirit Grandmasters are insignificant?"

"Hmph. You're from the Lower Heavens so Spirit Grandmasters are probably the peak of cultivation there and are revered by everyone and their mother. However, in this world, Spirit Grandmasters are only qualified to become bodyguards at best!"

"What? Bodyguards at best?" Wang Xiuying stared at him with a dazed look on her face, as she was having trouble imagining the power scale of this place.

"Just where are we, exactly?" Yuan asked him a moment later.

"You're currently in the Ancient Dragon City, a place isolated from the Nine Heavens. In other words, we don't belong to the Nine Heavens. However, if we were, we would probably exist somewhere in the middle of the Nine Heavens."

"So even higher than the Spirit Heavens? Amazing." Yuan expressed his admiration.

"Spirit Heavens? Hah! That place is like a backwater area compared to our sacred place!" Captain Cheng laughed out loud.

Sometime later, Yuan asked, "By the way, where are we heading? We've been traveling for almost an hour now."

"It's a place that's too good for you humans, that's for sure. We're almost there. I'll explain it more once we get there."

A few more minutes later, Captain Cheng started descending from the skies.

"That's... a palace? What a beautiful place." Yuan expressed his admiration for the palace made out of white jade.

"A breathtaking place, indeed..." Wang Xiuying mumbled with a dazed look on her face.

Once they landed, Captain Cheng said to them, "This is the Dragon Palace, where the Royal Family lives."

"The Royal Family?" Wang Xiuying swallowed nervously. These people sound like incredible big shots! Why were they brought here? To meet the Royal Family?

"I will warn you now, and I will only warn you once. If you show even the slightest disrespect or hostility towards the Royal Family, I will immediately kill you on the spot." Captain Cheng warned them with a stern look on his face.

"Do you two understand?"

"Yes." They quickly nodded.

"Good. Then follow me." Captain Cheng then led them to the staircase where other guards were stationed.

'Wow, they're really all Spirit Grandmasters...' Yuan said to himself after seeing their cultivation.

Once they climbed the staircase, Captain Cheng brought them to the audience room, where the Royal Family was already seated.

'That's the Royal Family? They have such a powerful atmosphere around them!' Wang Xiuying could feel a suffocating pressure around her body just from looking at them.

"Stop right there!" Captain Cheng suddenly said to them once they got within a certain distance from the Royal Family.

Yuan and Wang Xiuying immediately stopped walking.

"Greet the Royal Family!" He continued.

"Uhh... Hello?" The two of them greeted the Royal Family awkwardly, as they have never met royalty before, much less greet them.

"The audacity! Why aren't you kneeling on the floor when you're greeting the Royal Family?! And what's with that greeting?! Do you have a death wish?! I even warned you right before we entered this place!" Captain Cheng roared at them before grabbing the sword by his side and raising it into the air, seemingly prepared to chop them to pieces.

"Aaah! Yuan!" Wang Xiuying shouted in a terrified voice.

Yuan subconsciously responded to Wang Xiuying's voice, and he immediately summoned the Empyrean Overlord and stood between Captain Cheng and Wang Xiuying, protecting her from him.

"Y-You! How dare you point a weapon at me! A mere human!" Captain Cheng's Spirit King cultivation base exploded from his body.

Cough

Wang Xiuying coughed up a mouthful of blood after experiencing Captain Cheng's tyrannical cultivation base. Yuan wasn't much better. Even with his talents, the disparity between Spirit Grandmaster and Spirit King was simply too much. Furthermore, his opponent was a dragon.

However, he wasn't just going to stand there and do nothing while Wang Xiuying was feeling pain.

But before he could really do anything, the middle-aged man sitting at the end of the room suddenly stood up and shouted in a loud voice, "Halt!"

A powerful aura that was far stronger than Captain Cheng's aura suddenly filled the place, yet it didn't hurt Yuan or Wang Xiuying. Instead, it canceled out Captain Cheng's aura.

Captain Cheng immediately withdrew his pressure after hearing the middle-aged man's words.

"Who told you to treat the guests so roughly, Captain Cheng?! If you'd hurt them or worse—killed them—the death sentence would be the least of your worries!" The middle-aged man exclaimed, shocking him.

"T-This subordinate was wrong!" Captain Cheng immediately knelt on the ground and apologized.

However, the middle-aged man ignored him and approached Yuan and Wang Xiuying.

"Be at ease, guests. Things had gotten out of hand just now, and it was never our intention." The middle-aged man said to Yuan with a friendly smile on his face.

Chapter 354 - Royal Family

Despite the middle-aged man's friendly approach, Yuan remained alert, keeping the Empyrean Overlord in his grasp.

"Captain Cheng, get out of our sight!" The middle-aged man turned to look at him.

"B-But I cannot leave these two here without any supervision—"

"Do you really think we need supervision for them?" The middle-aged man narrowed his eyes.

"T-This subordinate has asked a stupid question! Please excuse me!" Captain Cheng said before leaving the room with a reddened face.

Once Captain Cheng left the scene, the middle-aged man returned his attention to Yuan and said, "I'm Xi Shengmo, also known as the Dragon Emperor, ruler of the Ancient Dragon City. Behind me is my royal family."

The middle-aged woman nodded her head and said, "I'm Xi Mingze, also known as the Dragon Empress."

"Dragon Prince, Xi Murong," said the handsome young man in a prideful tone.

"Hello! I am Xi Meili, the youngest child! I have always wanted to meet humans!" The graceful young lady spoke with a bright smile on her face, complimenting her bright eyes.

"..."

Yuan felt oddly at ease after Xi Meili's introduction, and he lowered his sword.

He then turned to look at Wang Xiuying and asked her, "Are you okay?"

"Y-Yes... I am fine. I have experienced worse pain when I practiced my own medicine on myself..." She nodded her head after wiping the blood from her lips.

"Here, let me help you get these cuffs off." The Dragon Emperor snapped his fingers, causing the cuffs to open and fall onto the ground.

Once the situation calmed down, the Dragon Emperor returned to his seat and said to them, "I have heard the situation from Captain Cheng. You two arrived here by accident after encountering a formation in the Mystic Realm, correct?"

"That's right." Yuan nodded.

"Hmmm..."

After sitting there in silence with a pondering face, the Dragon Emperor spoke, "Come with me. I want to confirm something— whether it's all just a big coincidence or you're really the one."

"Confirm what?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

The Dragon Emperor stood up and said, "Our ancestors had a prophecy—that one day, a human will arrive at our Ancient Dragon City and complete the ritual."

"Ritual?" Wang Xiuying and Yuan looked at each other. This sounded dangerous in its own ways.

"Come with me, I'll show you." The Dragon Emperor said as he walked out of the room.

Yuan and Wang Xiuying followed him. Not that they really had a choice in the first place.

"Hey, why are you wearing a mask?"

The Dragon Princess, Xi Meili, suddenly appeared beside Yuan and asked him with a curious gaze on her pretty face.

"Oh, I have my reasons. But if you want me to take it off, I don't mind, since that reason doesn't apply in this place." Yuan said.

"I want to see your face if you don't mind." Xi Meili said.

Yuan nodded and removed the mask on his face, revealing to them his handsome and young face.

"Good enough?"

"Yes, you look much better than I'd imagined." Xi Meili chuckled.

"I'll take that as a compliment." Yuan smiled.

"What's the outside world like? Are there a lot of humans?" Xi Meili then asked.

"Yes, there are. The only thing different outside is that we're not surrounded by clouds like we're here. This reminds me, are we somewhere in the sky or something?" Yuan then asked.

"Nope. That's just how this world is. The ground is made of clouds, and the sky also has clouds."

"I see... What a mythical place." Yuan nodded.

Sometime later, they arrived at the ritual site, which was a couple of miles behind the Dragon Palace.

The ritual site itself wasn't anything too special. There were nine dragon statues placed in a circle formation, and in the middle of this formation was a crystal ball shaped like a dragon's head.

"What are we supposed to do here?" Yuan asked them.

"Do you see that crystal ball in the middle?" The Dragon Emperor asked him, and he continued without waiting for a response, "That is the Crystal of Fate. If you drop your blood onto it, the Crystal of Fate will evaluate your talents, and the dragon statues will release a pillar of light that corresponds to your talents."

"If you can somehow make all nine dragon statues release a pillar of light, a treasure will reveal itself. This treasure was left behind by our ancestors, and we have been trying to obtain it for millions of years now. However, we've never been able to release all nine pillars of light— only seven at most."

"Now this is where their prophecy comes into play. They said that one day, someone— a human will arrive in our world and release all nine pillars of light."

"Hmph! As if a mere human could possibly have more talents than us dragons!" The Dragon Prince suddenly snorted.

He then looked at Yuan and said, "Just so you know, I have managed to release 7 pillars of light! And I am recognized as one of the most talented dragons since our ancestors' era!"

"If you can release more pillars of light than I did, I will lower my head and call you boss!"

"Ehhh..." Yuan was at loss for words.

"By the way, I also managed to release seven pillars of light." Xi Meili said a moment later.

"Now which one of you would like to go first? The prophecy only mentioned a single human, so I wasn't expecting two." The Dragon Emperor said to them.

Yuan then said, "If we help you in this ritual, will you help us return to our own place?"

"As in return to the Mystic Realm? That's going to be a little tricky since it's been a long time since anyone has left this world, but we'll try to assist you to the best of our abilities."

"I understand." Yuan nodded, then he turned to look at Wang Xiuying and asked her, "Do you want to go first?"

"I do!" Wang Xiuying immediately nodded her head.

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Chapter 355 - Dragon Awakening Ritual

"Okay, then this young lady shall go first." The Dragon Emperor nodded his head at Wang Xiuying.

Wang Xiuying then approached the crystal ball in the middle of the formation.

"I just need to drop some of my blood onto this crystal ball, right?" She asked for confirmation.

"That is correct. You may use the dagger beside the Crystal of Fate to release your blood. Just a few drops will be enough." The Dragon Emperor nodded.

Wang Xiuying grabbed the cool-looking dagger with a dragon design on the handle and poked a small hole on the tip of her finger.

She then squeezed a few drops of blood onto the crystal ball.

The crystal ball immediately absorbed her blood and began glowing a subtle golden light.

A few seconds later, one of the dragon statues emitted a golden aura before shooting into the sky.

A few more seconds later, a second dragon statue released a pillar of golden light into the sky.

Then, a third pillar of light appeared in the sky for all of the people in the city to see.

"Someone is partaking in the Dragon Awakening Ritual? Who could it be?"

The people in the city stopped whatever they were doing to spectate the ritual like they always do.

However, the ritual ended sooner than the people had expected, as the pillars of lights had stopped at three.

"Hahaha! Which trash is participating in the ritual? Three pillars of light? That's pathetic!"

"When was the last time someone released only three pillars? I don't remember!"

The people spectating the ritual from afar burst out laughing when they saw the results.

Meanwhile, at the ritual site, Xi Murong slapped his thighs and laughed out loud, "Three?! Hahaha! How laughable!"

"I guess you're not the one..." The Dragon Emperor shook his head at Wang Xiuying, who returned with a somewhat embarrassed expression on her face.

"Don't mind it, young lady. Releasing three pillars of light is actually very good for someone from the Lower Heavens. You should be proud of yourself." Xi Meili approached Wang Xiuying to comfort her.

"Thank you, Dragon Princess..." Wang Xiuying said with a slight smile on her face.

"I am serious, young lady. Releasing three pillars of light is an incredible feat for a human. This Dragon Awakening Ritual is meant for dragons. If other humans in the Lower Heavens were to take this ritual, they might not even be able to release a single pillar." Xi Meili reassured her that it was nothing to be embarrassed about.

"If you say it like that, I guess..." The smile on Wang Xiuying's face became less stiff and more genuine.

"Young man, it's your turn." The Dragon Emperor looked at Yuan.

Since Wang Xiuying failed, it was very likely that Yuan is the person mentioned in the prophecy, but there is also the chance that neither of them has anything to do with the prophecy and that they'd truly arrived in this place by accident.

Sometime later, Yuan approached the crystal ball shaped like a dragon's head and took a deep breath.

He then dropped some of his blood onto it.

Once the crystal ball absorbed his blood, it immediately began to glow golden, and it was emitting a light that was noticeably more colorful than Wang Xiuying's attempt.

A few seconds later, the first pillar of light was released, piercing straight into the heavens.

The second pillar appeared a few more seconds later, as did the third and fourth.

"Look! Someone else is partaking in the Dragon Awakening Ritual!"

"Four pillars, huh? At least this person is already better than the last one."

"Obtaining three pillars will guarantee that they will reach Spirit Grandmaster. Four pillars mean they have the talent to reach Spirit Lord."

A few seconds later, the fifth pillar appeared.

"Five pillars! This person will reach at least Spirit King! Not bad!"

"Ooooh! Six pillars! Someone has managed to obtain six pillars! This person is, without a doubt, a genius! Spirit Emperor is guaranteed for this person as long as he or she lives long enough!"

"H-Heavens! Seven pillars! This person has managed to get seven pillars! He's on the same level as the children from the Royal Family!"

"Whoever this person is, his future is looking great!"

"S-Seven pillars...?" Xi Murong, the Dragon Prince, swallowed nervously upon seeing this, and an ominous feeling appeared in his guts.

However, the eighth pillar didn't appear after the seventh pillar— at least not within just a few seconds like usual.

Just as Xi Murong sighed in relief that Yuan stopped at seven pillars of light, the eighth dragon statue began emitting a golden aura before shooting it into the skies, shocking the spectators.

"E-Eight! Eight pillars! Whoever this individual is— he's managed to rival the ancestors in terms of talents!"

The spectators were shaking in excitement when they saw this.

The Dragon Emperor also trembled with excitement and anticipation when he saw this.

'He's the one! There's no way he isn't the one in the prophecy!' The Dragon Emperor was almost certain at this point that Yuan was the one they have been waiting for— the one who'll help them reveal their ancestors' treasure!

A whole minute after Yuan released the eighth pillar of light, the Ancient Dragon City suddenly began to shake, which shook the residences greatly, as they have never experienced an earthquake in this world before.

In fact, natural earthquakes cannot happen in this world, so this was a phenomenon caused by something unnatural!

"W-What's happening?"

The earthquake was so powerful that it'd knocked many people onto the ground.

A few moments into the earthquake, the ninth dragon statue suddenly began to emit a golden aura.

However, what came out of the ninth statue wasn't a pillar of light. Instead, the hologram of a dragon appeared from the statue and flew towards the sky before circling around the world like some kind of guardian.

In fact, this dragon somewhat resembled the dragon that appeared at the Dragon Essence Temple after Yuan cleared all 100 floors of the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower!

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Chapter 356 - Dragon Ancestor

The moment this dragon appeared in the sky, the Dragon Emperor and his family could feel their blood reacting to the dragon.

"Ancestor!"

The Dragon Emperor and the others immediately kowtowed on the ground and bowed to the dragon in the sky.

If one were to see the Ancient Dragon City from above right now, one would see that every person in this city was kowtowing at this moment.

Unexpectedly, the ancestor of the Royal Family had been summoned after awakening the ninth dragon statue.

"This dragon looks familiar... The Great One?" Yuan sort of recognized this dragon in the sky, as it resembled the Great One he has met multiple times by now.

After circling around the sky above the Ancient Dragon City exactly nine times, the golden dragon stopped flying and turned to stare at the city with its powerful gaze that sent chills down everyone's spine.

The Dragon Ancestor then narrowed its eyes at the area behind the Dragon Palace, or more specifically, the individual who was standing in the Dragon Awakening Ritual— Yuan.

"So you have finally returned..." The Dragon Ancestor spoke.

And it continued, "Oh, before you respond or ask me anything, I am merely a recording, so I won't be able to answer your questions."

After a moment of silence, the Dragon Ancestor continued, "The fact that you've summoned me means you've finally made it to my humble world. You may or may not remember anything, but this is proof that you're on the right track. However, coming here is just the beginning. You still have a long journey before you will accomplish your goals."

"And just like we have arranged, I have left behind for you a small gift. I hope to see you soon at the peak."

After a small pause, the Dragon Ancestor continued, "Now as for my family... I don't know who is in charge right now or what you're doing, but I want you to treat my little friend here right. Consider this request my will or something like that. You won't regret it, I promise."

"Until next time, my friend."

The Dragon Ancestor disappeared from the sky shortly after saying his words, dumbfounding everybody in the Ancient Dragon City, as nobody there had any idea what their ancestor was talking about.

However, to call someone its 'friend', this person must be fairly important to the Dragon Ancestor.

Once the Dragon Ancestor disappeared, the ninth and final pillar of light appeared in the sky.

It was at this moment a massive magic circle appeared in the sky above the Ancient Dragon City.

"What the heck is that?!" Xi Murong cried out loud when he saw this formation.

"Such a thing existed above the city? Even I didn't know this!" The Dragon Emperor was also shocked to see the formation.

A few moments later, this formation in the sky released a powerful light that basked everyone in the Ancient Dragon City.

"Father! I can feel my body growing more powerful! I think this light is affecting our bloodline!" Xi Meili suddenly exclaimed.

"What?!"

When Xi Meili mentioned their bloodline, the Dragon Emperor and Dragon Empress immediately checked their bodies, and sure enough, their bloodlines had improved!

The formation in the sky disappeared exactly a minute later, and a small object could be seen descending from the sky afterward.

This object descended towards the Dragon Palace and hovered in front of Yuan sometime later.

"This is... a drop of blood?" Yuan grabbed the bottle that contained a single drop of blood inside.

[You have completed the Hidden Quest: Dragon Awakening Ritual]

[You have obtained 'Dragon Ancestor's Blood Essence']

[You have obtained Fame +500]

Peace quickly returned to the Ancient Dragon City, but the people there were still filled with shock and disbelief about the events today, and they will remain that way for the next couple of days.

"Y-Young man, what was your name again?" The Dragon Emperor looked at Yuan with a complicated look on his face.

"Yuan."

"Do you think I can take a look at that treasure, Yuan? Don't worry, I won't take it from you. The ancestor has already spoken. That treasure belongs to whoever manages to release all nine pillars of light." The Dragon Emperor reassured him that they won't take away the treasure.

After all, if they went against their ancestors' wishes, it might affect their bloodline, and no treasure in this world is worth more than their own bloodline.

Yuan nodded and handed him the bottle.

The Royal Family gathered around the Dragon Emperor and looked at the drop of blood inside the bottle.

"My bloodline is reacting to this drop of blood." Xi Meili said.

"Mine as well." Xi Murong agreed.

"I think this drop of blood belongs to the ancestor..." The Dragon Emperor said.

"If that's true, this drop of blood is too precious to be given to a human! We cannot give it to him! It'll be worth more in our hands!" Xi Murong said.

Pap!

"Ah!"

Xi Murong suddenly cried out loud in a painful voice when the Dragon Empress slapped him.

She then said with a frown on her face, "Were you asleep just now when the Dragon Ancestor spoke? The Dragon Ancestor wants this treasure to be given to Yuan, so it will be given to him! No questions asked! Unless you want to challenge the Dragon Ancestor!"

"I-I don't dare!" Xi Murong quickly said.

Challenge the Dragon Ancestor who dominated the Nine Heavens and created this utopia for them? He'd be cursed to death by everyone around him regardless of his status as Dragon Prince!

Sometime later, the Dragon Emperor handed the bottle back to Yuan and said to him, "Please take care of this treasure, Yuan. This drop of blood is

worth more than you can possibly fathom— it's not something a human being should hold if I have to be completely honest with you."

"I understand. Thank you." Yuan nodded and accepted the bottle of blood.

"Umm... Do you have something I can use to hold it? I don't have my spatial ring with me."

The Dragon Emperor nodded and said, "Of course. We have plenty of those. Come with me."

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Chapter 357 - Xi Meili

Sometime later, Yuan and Wang Xiuying followed the Royal Family back into the Dragon Palace.

"Congratulations, Yuan. You've managed to obtain a treasure that even Immortals would kill for." Xi Meili said to him.

"Immortals? How powerful are Immortals?" Yuan asked.

"Real Immortals are extremely powerful. They're so powerful that even my parents cannot do anything to them despite their cultivation bases." Xi Meili said, and she continued, "By the way, my parents are one realm above Spirit Emperors— Spirit Sovereigns."

"I see... but what can I do with this drop of blood? Can I consume it?" Yuan then asked.

After all, he's already consumed phoenix blood before.

"Yes. You can consume it to increase the grade of your bloodline. And depending on your bloodline, it might increase the grade of your bloodline by more than one grade! Crazy, right? Humans would go to war for this drop of blood." Xi Meili said.

"How lucky, Yuan. You have once again obtained something incredible." Wang Xiuying congratulated him.

And she continued, "I'm beginning to understand how you were able to achieve the things you had achieved."

"It just happens," Yuan said with a smile on his face.

Sometime later, the Dragon Emperor handed Yuan a spatial ring, "Here, you can use this to store your treasures."

[Dragon Spatial Ring]

[Grade: Heaven]

[Mental Strength Required: 25,000]

[Description: A pouch that contains its own space. Much larger than normal Spatial Rings. Can hold a few hundred watermelons inside.]

"Thank you." Yuan accepted the ring before storing the Dragon Ancestor's Blood Essence inside.

"Now, regarding your way back to the Lower Heavens... We can try to activate the teleport formation you guys came from, but that will require some time and research since it's been a very long time since we last used it." The Dragon Emperor said to them.

"How long do you think it'll take, Senior Xi?" Wang Xiuying asked him.

"At least a week," he responded.

"A week, huh... As long as we can get back before the Mystic Realm event ends..." she nodded.

"You can stay here in the meantime. I will assign some servants to you—"

"I will do it!" Xi Meili suddenly interrupted, even volunteering for the job.

"You will?" Her father looked at her with raised eyebrows.

"You guys don't mind, right? I want to spend as much time as I can with you two before you leave this place. Who knows, maybe this will be my last time seeing humans." Xi Meili said.

"I don't mind," Yuan said.

"Me neither." Wang Xiuying agreed.

"Great! Lunch is about to be served, so we can decide what you want to do afterward. Maybe I can show you around the city or something." Xi Meili suggested.

"That sounds like a great idea." As someone who loves to explore, Yuan agreed with her suggestion.

Xi Meili then brought them to the guest room, where they drank tea and talked about random things until lunch was prepared.

"What's life like here? You can't leave this place, right? It reminds me of the people inside the Mystic Realm since they also cannot leave that world." Yuan asked Xi Meili.

"It's not that we cannot leave this place. We can leave whenever we want, but nobody really wants to go outside." Xi Meili revealed to him.

"Really? Why? Aren't you bored of staying in this one place for the rest of your life?" Yuan then asked.

"Although I don't know how big the outside world is, I was told that the Ancient Dragon City was comparable to an entire continent outside. And while it does get boring sometimes, at least we're safe in this world."

"I heard from my parents that the outside world is incredibly dangerous with life-threatening existences roaming everywhere. In this world, people rarely die from unnatural causes, and everyone can live for tens of thousands of years without any worries."

"What an incredible place... It sounds almost like a paradise." Wang Xiuying said, feeling a little envious of their peaceful life.

"Yes!" Xi Meili nodded her head with a bright expression on her face, and she continued to speak, "Furthermore, everyone in this world is from the dragon race, so we don't have to worry about arguing with the other races, which is incredibly common in the outside world from what I heard."

"I see... By the way, what cultivation are you? I cannot sense your cultivation base." Yuan suddenly asked her, as he has been wondering about this for a while now.

"Me? I'm a Spirit Emperor," she casually said.

"Spirit Emperor?! If you don't mind me asking, how old are you?" Wang Xiuying asked her.

"I will be 10,169 years old next month."

"Ten thousand years old?! You don't look that old!" Wang Xiuying said, feeling a little envious of Xi Meili. If only she could be 100 years old and look like she was in her early twenties, much less 10,000 years old— that would be the dream of every female in the real world.

"Old? I'm still very young. My brother is almost 30,000 years old. As for my parents, they're well over 100,000 years old!" Xi Meili said.

"What's the average lifespan for an ordinary dragon?" Yuan asked out of curiosity.

"About 50,000 years, but that number increases drastically with cultivation."

"50,000 years..." Yuan mumbled in a dazed voice.

The cultivation world is truly unfathomable and filled with wonders.

"What about you two? How old are you?" Xi Meili asked them next.

"I'm 18 years old." Wang Xiuying said.

"I'm also 18 years old," Yuan said.

"Wait... You're only 18 years old?" Xi Meili looked at Yuan with a gawking expression on her pretty face.

"Yes?" Yuan said in a questioning tone.

"And you're already a Spirit Grandmaster? As expected of someone who managed to release all nine pillars of light... Your talents are truly terrifying." Xi Meili said.

Sometime later, a servant notified them that lunch was prepared.

"Let's go eat for now. We can talk more later." Xi Meili said, escorting them to the dining room shortly after.

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Chapter 358 - A Dragons Pride

Chapter 358 - A Dragon's Pride

Once Xi Meili brought them to the dining room, they were greeted by a large table that was filled with food from the center to the edge of the table.

There was so much food on the table that it looked like a feast for 100 people.

Wang Xiuying was left speechless by this. Surely, they didn't have to cook that much food for just six people, right?

"That's a lot of food," Yuan said out loud after seeing it.

Xi Meili chuckled and said, "We're dragons— we eat a lot."

"Come, take a seat." The Dragon Emperor said to them with a bright smile on his face, clearly in a very blissful mood.

A few moments later, once they were all seated, the Dragon Emperor spoke again, "Yuan, I will raise this cup for you, who released all nine pillars of light and made history today, even helping us improve our bloodlines."

"Thank you, Yuan." The Dragon Empress also raised her cup.

"Che. As much as I hate to admit it, you're pretty good for a human." Xi Murong also raised his cup.

After spending some time alone, Xi Murong realized that Yuan wasn't like the other humans and that he was qualified to be acknowledged by them.

"If I remember correctly, you promised to address Yuan as 'boss' if he managed to release more pillars than you, Elder Brother." Xi Meili reminded him as she raised her cup.

"S-Shut up! Why did you have to remind him!" Xi Murong's face quickly flushed with redness.

"Go ahead. Eat whatever you want and as much as you want!" The Dragon Emperor said to them before digging in.

The Royal Family immediately started grabbing the food and tossed them into their mouths, taking large bites and eating them in a somewhat barbaric manner, completely unbecoming of their status.

Wang Xiuying was left speechless by their eating manner, but when she thought about it, they were not human, and their eating resembled how magical beasts would eat their food.

"Wow, these foods have so much spiritual energy in them! They taste great!" Yuan exclaimed after swallowing a mouthful of food.

"Almost everything on this table was raised by the Royal Family. I'm glad you like it." The Dragon Emperor laughed.

"I can feel my cultivation base soaring just from eating... I have never experienced this before!" Wang Xiuying managed to enter the Spirit Warrior realm after swallowing a few mouthfuls of food.

"Most of them are raised to Spirit Grandmaster before we eat them, so you're consuming Spirit Grandmaster spiritual meat. You'll most likely increase a few more levels during this lunch." Xi Meili said to her.

"S-Spirit Grandmaster spiritual meat... I don't know about the Spirit Heavens, but the Lower Heavens definitely don't have such luxury..." Wang Xiuying mumbled, and she quickly began stuffing more food inside her mouth, as this was a great opportunity to raise her cultivation easily.

'It was the right choice to follow Yuan! If I continue following him, who knows what might happen. I might even become a top player just by following him!' Wang Xiuying thought to herself.

'Unfortunately, I am not playing this game to become the best player out there.'

Since her main objective was to find a cure for Yu Tian in this vast cultivation world, she will be focusing on that.

'If I can go to the Spirit Heavens, I will be able to learn even more things! I might even find a cure for Yu Tian!' Wang Xiuying thought.

Sometime later, once they had consumed over half of the food on the table, the Royal Family began worrying if they would have enough food or not, as they had underestimated Yuan's eating capabilities.

'Heavens! This human's appetite is as big as us dragons! And dragons are known for having huge appetites compared to the other races!' Xi Murong cried inwardly when he realized how much Yuan had eaten.

Meanwhile, Wang Xiuying had stopped eating long ago, and she was on the verge of collapsing from eating too much. However, she'd managed to increase her cultivation base to ninth-level Spirit Warrior from her effort.

"Tell the cooks to bring us more food! And tell them to not stop cooking until I say so!" The Dragon Emperor commanded the servants there, as he wasn't going to risk running out of food, which would be an embarrassment for their family.

A royal family running out of food during a feast? If word got out, they would become laughing stocks!

"If there's not enough food, you don't have to mind me," Yuan said to them with an innocent face.

"Hahaha! Nonsense! Eat as much as you want! In fact, don't stop eating until you're full!" The Dragon Emperor said.

Yuan nodded and continued to stuff his face with more food.

When Xi Murong saw this, he quickened his eating pace, not wanting to lose to Yuan for a second time.

'Although you might have beaten me in terms of talent, I will never let you beat me when it comes to eating! My pride as a dragon is on the line here!' Xi Murong cried inwardly.

A few hours and a couple hundred pounds of food later, Yuan patted his round stomach and finally stopped eating.

"I am full!" He said with a satisfied look on his face, as it has been a long time since he'd been this full.

"Yes! I won!" Xi Murong said with a somewhat sick look on his face.

"Huh?" Yuan looked at Xi Murong who was looking in his direction with a prideful look, unaware of the battle they just had.

"Are you sure you're really human and don't actually have a dragon bloodline?" Xi Meili chuckled.

"I'm pretty sure I am human..." Yuan smiled.

"Anyways, it's getting late, so we'll have to visit the city tomorrow. I'll show you the guest rooms now if you're ready to move." Xi Meili said to them.

"Give me a few minutes..." Yuan said while pointing at his round belly.

"Me too." Wang Xiuying also said.

"Don't worry. Take all the time you need. I'll go prepare your rooms now." Xi Meili said to them before leaving the dining room.

Chapter 359 - Rivals

While Xi Meili went to prepare their rooms, the Dragon Emperor remained in the room with them and spoke, "Yuan, if you have any questions for me, now is the best time."

"Now that you mention it, I have had something on my mind ever since I saw the Dragon Ancestor. Just who is the Dragon Ancestor? And is he related to the 'Great One'?" Yuan asked.

The Dragon Emperor immediately frowned upon hearing Yuan mention the Great One, and he spoke in a serious voice, "Where... Where did you hear about the Great One?"

"Oh, I met him a few times— well, not actually in person, but I have spoken with his illusions a couple of times," Yuan said.

"I see..."

The Dragon Emperor closed his eyes for a moment before speaking, "The Dragon Ancestor and the 'Great One' are not related at all. The Dragon Ancestor is an incredibly powerful Divine Beast who has existed since the primordial era with multiple empires across the Nine Heavens, and this Ancient Dragon City is merely one of them. As for the Great One, he was born in the same era as the Dragon Ancestor, and they were rivals of sorts, both racing to the peak."

"Rivals, huh... Do you know who won?" Yuan asked.

"Sorry, but I can't tell you, as I don't have the answer to your question. According to the rumors, they were both equally as talented, so who knows, really."

"I see..." Yuan mumbled.

"Then do you know where I can find the Great One?"

"Unfortunately, the Great One isn't someone you can just 'find'. You must have a strong destiny if you want to find him, and even then, you don't know when or where you'll find him." The Dragon Emperor said.

"And from my knowledge, the Great One is always traveling the Nine Heavens."

"I see..." Yuan nodded.

"By the way, I have been wondering as well... What was the Dragon Ancestor talking about? They had anticipated your arrival and even expected that you'd release all 9 pillars of light. It seemed like they had arranged for everything that happened today."

"Honestly, I also have no idea. This is my first time in this place, and I have never met any dragons besides the Great One before coming here." Yuan shrugged.

"How weird..." The Dragon Emperor mumbled. The Dragon Ancestor definitely expected Yuan's arrival, even speaking to him as though he was very familiar with Yuan. Of course, it was only a recording, but something felt odd about this situation.

Sometime later, Xi Meili returned and said, "Your rooms are prepared. Can you guys walk now?"

"Yes, I can. Thank you." Yuan nodded as he stood up from his chair, feeling as though he'd gained some weight overall.

Thus, Yuan and Wang Xiuying followed Xi Meili to their rooms.

"Wow, what a massive room. I have never been to such a luxurious room before, and I have been to many high-grade hotels because of my grandpa!" Wang Xiuying exclaimed.

As the granddaughter of one of the most famous doctors in the world, it was only natural that Wang Xiuying would have plenty of experience as a rich young lady.

However, no hotel in their world could rival a mere guest room in the Dragon Palace that was as spacious as an entire house.

"Yuan, your room is right next door." Xi Meili said to him.

"Okay. Thank you."

"I'll leave you two alone to rest now. Tomorrow, I will show you guys around the city, okay?"

"That sounds great." Yuan nodded.

"Great. Then goodnight!" Xi Meili said to them before leaving and returning to her own room.

"This is such a wonderful room that I'm going to sleep in here tonight instead of my own room!" Wang Xiuying declared with an excited look on her face.

"What happened to sleeping every day?" Yuan said with a teasing smile on his face.

"S-Shut it! Once in a while is fine! And I am still technically sleeping! It's just that I'll be doing it inside the game!" She quickly refuted, her face slightly rosy.

"Then I'll see you later. Goodnight." Yuan said to her before going to his own room.

"Goodnight, Yuan."

A few moments later, Yuan entered his own room and looked around, paying the most attention to the ancient-looking furniture.

After spending many minutes looking around the place, Yuan jumped onto the large bed that could easily fit an entire family of four.

"Wow, what a comfortable bed. I have never experienced anything like this before..." Yuan felt as though he was sleeping on clouds when he laid on the bed.

Sometime later, he retrieved the Dragon Ancestor's Blood Essence and stared at it silently.

"I really want to consume this right now, but it's probably better to wait until I return to Feng Feng's side so I can ask for advice. I can't be so hasty with such a priceless treasure, after all."

With that in mind, Yuan stored the dragon blood back into the Dragon Spatial Ring.

Yuan logged off the game shortly after for dinner.

"Yuan, something happened outside the Mystic Realm today," Meixiu said to him as she fed him dinner.

"What happened?"

"A pillar of light shot out of the Mystic Realm," she said.

"Eh? Really? What caused this pillar of light?" Yuan was unaware that the pillar of light was created by the teleport formation.

"Nobody knows. However, the pillar of light came from the Mystic Pagoda, so something probably happened there,' she then said.

"Hm? Mystic Pagoda?" Yuan suddenly realized something.

"I think I know why..." He then said.

"Really? What caused it?"

"This is going to be a little long, so I'll tell you after dinner," Yuan said.

"Okay."

After feeding Yuan dinner and cleaning the mess, she returned to his room for his long story.

"Let's see... where should I begin?"

After pondering for a moment, Yuan began recalling what he'd experienced in the Mystic Realm today, starting from how he entered the Mystic Pagoda with Wang Xiuying before being teleported to this weird place where only dragons lived.

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Chapter 360 - Serious Implications

"Ancient Dragon City...? So are you still inside the Mystic Realm or not?" Meixiu asked him after hearing his story.

"I don't think so."

"But you still have your cultivation base, right? Shouldn't your cultivation base return to your original cultivation base— maybe a little more after you leave the place?" Meixiu asked.

"Now that you mention it, I still had my Mystic Realm cultivation base at the Ancient Dragon City. Maybe it's a phenomenon because I didn't leave the Mystic Realm the proper way?"

"That's the only logical explanation for it, I guess," Meixiu mumbled.

"Anyways, what are you going to do now? Do you have a way to return to the Mystic Realm?"

"I have no idea how to return, but the Dragon Emperor said he'll try to do something about it, so we can only rely on him for now."

"Do you want me to tell the Sect Master and the others?" Meixiu then asked.

"I don't want them to worry so let's keep this a secret for now, and it's not like we're in danger or anything," Yuan said.

"Okay."

Sometime later, Meixiu left his room whilst Yuan went back inside the game, mostly because he wanted to sleep in the Dragon Palace that was

much more comfortable than his own room, just like Wang Xiuying.

"Ahhh, this bed is perfect..." Yuan closed his eyes and fully indulged himself in the comfort, feeling as though he was surrounded by fluffy clouds, and he quickly fell asleep.

The following morning, Yuan was woken up by a knock at the door.

"Yuan, are you awake?" Xi Meili's voice resounded from outside.

"Yes... I am awake..." Yuan responded in a sleepy voice.

"I just want to let you know that breakfast will be ready soon so if you're hungry, just go to the dining room in about an hour."

"Okay. I'll be there." Yuan said to her.

Shortly after waking up, Yuan logged off for Meixiu's breakfast.

"By the way, Doctor Wang texted me this morning. He said that he'll be here in a bit."

"Okay."

About half an hour after breakfast, Doctor Wang knocked on their door.

"I know this is a bit earlier than usual, but I'll be busy later, so I hope you don't mind." Doctor Wang said after he arrived.

"Don't worry about it, Doctor Wang. I'm grateful that you would come here even when you're so busy."

Doctor Wang proceeded to check Yuan's health and body.

"As expected, your body is growing stronger and stronger. However, it's very weird that despite having a body that's healthier than even some athletes, you are still unable to move your body, almost like there is an invisible force preventing you from moving."

"If I wasn't a doctor, I would believe that you had been cursed or something." Doctor Wang said.

"Cursed? Haha... That's very funny, Doctor Wang." Yuan chuckled, as he didn't believe in these kinds of things.

"I am serious, Young Master. Your situation makes no sense at all. You're not sick. Your body is fine. We have tested your blood, your bones, your muscles— everything. However, we couldn't find anything wrong with your body. I also don't believe in superstitions, but your situation is making me doubt my own beliefs!" Doctor Wang said.

"..."

After a moment of silence, Yuan said, "Meixiu, are you here?"

"Yes, I am."

"Sorry, but can you leave for a moment? I'd like to speak with Doctor Wang privately."

"Okay," Meixiu said before leaving the room and closing the door behind her.

"We're alone now, Young Master. What do you have for me?" Doctor Wang asked him.

Yuan didn't say anything, only lifting one of his arms a little off the bed.

"WHAT?! Y-YOU—"

"Lower your voice, Doctor Wang!" Yuan quickly interrupted him.

Doctor Wang subconsciously covered his mouth with his hands, and he stared at Yuan with his eyes wide with shock.

Once he'd calmed down enough, he spoke, "Y-Young Master... Since when can you...?"

"A couple of weeks ago, I guess," Yuan said.

"I'm sorry for keeping this a secret, but I wanted to wait until I could move properly so that I could surprise you all."

"Who else besides myself knows about this?" Doctor Wang asked him.

"Only you and Miss Meifeng know about this," Yuan said.

"Meifeng? Meixiu's mother?"

"Yes."

"Tell me more about this, Young Master. Did it suddenly happen? Or did you do something special?" Doctor Wang asked.

"Well... My recovery began when I started playing Cultivation Online."

"What? That super popular game that's currently dominating the world? My granddaughter also plays it."

"This is going to sound crazy, but I think the game somehow affects our real body as well. Although I have no concrete proof, I have a feeling that's what is happening." Yuan said.

"Indeed, that does sound a little... No, it definitely sounds crazy." Doctor Wang agreed with him.

"I know, but Doctor Wang, do you remember when I was covered in that smelly stuff?"

"The impurities? There's no way I could ever forget about that, and I can still smell the stench very clearly." Doctor Wang shuddered just thinking about the stench.

"Well, to tell you the truth, that also happened to me when I was playing the game. I ate some kind of treasure that cleansed all of the impurities from my body. When I logged off the game, I was shocked to find out that it'd also happened to my real body."

"Hmmm..." Doctor Wang pondered with a serious look on his face.

"I understand. I will do my own investigation as well. If it's true that this game can somehow affect the real body, it will have some serious implications that could change the world." Doctor Wang said.

"Oh, I'll also keep this matter between us, so you don't have to worry about that."

"Thank you, Doctor Wang."

"Anyways, it's a great thing that you're finally recovering. It's been long overdue. I cannot wait to see you walk on your own again." Doctor Wang said with a genuine smile on his face.

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Chapter 361 - Changing Diet

"By the way, I am thinking about changing your diet back to normal. What do you think, Young Master?" Doctor Wang suddenly asked him.

"Change my diet? You mean I get to eat normal food again?" Yuan asked him in an excited voice, as it has been many years since he'd last tasted real food— in the real world at least.

"Yes, but it will be in small portions since your body will need to get adjusted to eating such food again."

"Also, you will need to speak with Meixiu about this, since she will be the one cooking it." Doctor Wang said, and he continued, "Shall we get Meixiu back in here?"

"Yes."

Sometime later, Doctor Wang called Meixiu back into the room.

"So I have decided to change the Young Master's diet and see if he can eat real food again. Are you okay with that, Meixiu? You'll be the one preparing all of the food, after all. If you need help, there are paid services out there that will help you cook the food and deliver it to your door." Doctor Wang explained to her.

"I can cook the food by myself," Meixiu said without hesitation, as that was what she had been trained to do.

"Okay, then I will send you the menu in three days. You can continue feeding the Young Master soup for now." Doctor Wang said.

"I understand." Meixiu nodded.

Doctor Wang left shortly after.

Yuan returned to the game, and he immediately went to the dining room.

"I'm sorry for arriving a little late. I was busy with something." Yuan apologized to them.

"It's fine. Let's eat before the food goes cold." The Dragon Emperor said to him before digging into the food.

Breakfast lasted for an hour, and although it was not a feast, there was as much food as their previous meal.

After breakfast, Xi Meili asked them, "Do you want to visit the city today?"

"I do." Yuan immediately nodded.

"If you're going, I will go as well." Wang Xiuying said.

"Okay, then let's go."

Once Yuan had rested enough to walk properly, Xi Meili brought them outside and proceeded to escort them around the city.

"You don't need guards?" Wang Xiuying asked her.

In her mind, princesses like her usually would have a bodyguard or two just in case something happens.

"Haha... You think I need a guard? I can protect myself just fine. And who would dare to mess with me? They have nowhere to run or hide in this world. Besides, I am only weaker than my parents and a few individuals in this world." Xi Meili said with a confident smile on her face.

Sometime later, once they were on the streets, everybody they passed through would bow to them— or more specifically, Xi Meili.

"Good morning, Your Highness."

"Good morning, Dragon Princess!"

"Good morning, everybody!" Xi Meili returned their greetings with a bright smile on her face.

"Wow, do you have a good relationship with everyone?" Yuan asked her, as he has never seen anyone so easy-going before.

"Of course! In such a small world, it would be more beneficial for everyone if we have a good relationship with each other."

"That makes sense. If only it was the same outside." Yuan sighed.

"Today, I want to show you guys the Ancestral Dragon Temple; it was created by our Dragon Ancestor." Xi Meili said.

"Ancestral Dragon Temple? What kind of place is it?" Yuan asked, as it sounded similar to the Dragon Essence Temple's Dragon Temple.

"It's something like a playground for us dragons, and there are prizes if we win." Xi Meili said.

"A playground? That sounds very interesting!" Yuan's anticipation immediately went up, as he has never been to a playground before.

"It's a little bit far from here so bear with me. Of course, we can fly there, but that will take away the point of showing you the city."

"It's okay, we can walk there," Yuan said.

Thus, they continued to make their way to the Ancestral Dragon Temple. On the way there, Xi Meili would give a history lesson on some of the buildings they passed.

About two hours later, they arrived at the Ancestral Dragon Temple, which was filled with people.

"This is a playground? It doesn't look like one." Wang Xiuying said with her eyebrows raised.

After all, playgrounds don't have arenas— at least they shouldn't.

"This is where dragons go to have fun." Xi Meili said.

And she continued, "And yes, we have fun by fighting with each other."

"There are seven arenas in this place. You can challenge whoever you want —"

"Oh my god! He died!" Wang Xiuying suddenly exclaimed, interrupting Xi Meili.

On the stage, one of the fighters had decapitated his opponent.

Xi Meili chuckled at her reaction and said, "Don't worry, he's not really dead."

A few moments later, the 'dead' fighter suddenly disappeared from the stage and appeared outside the stage with his head reattached to his body, and the person himself looked perfectly healthy.

"There's a formation in these arenas. As long as you stand on it, even if your body is destroyed, you will not truly die. This allows the fighters to go all out on each other. However, you will not be able to enter the stage for one week if you die because your body can only handle so much of the formation. If you die twice in a short time, the formation might not work properly." Xi Meili explained to them.

She then pointed to another arena and continued, "That arena over there also has a formation that can limit both fighters to a certain cultivation base so they can fight on fairer terms. For example, if a Spirit Grandmaster wants to fight a Spirit King fairly, he can do so by fighting in that arena, where both of them will be Spirit Grandmasters. Does the Lower Heavens have something like this?"

"I don't think so... At least I have never heard of such a thing until today," Yuan said.

"That's not unexpected, since these formations are pretty powerful and not something the Lower Heavens should have." Xi Meili said.

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Chapter 362 - Ancestral Dragon Temple

"Look! It's Her Highness, Princess Xi! Good morning, Princess Xi!"

When someone there noticed her presence and announced it, everyone there turned to bow to her, and even the fighters on the stage stopped fighting momentarily just to bow to her.

"Morning, everybody! Please, continue what you're doing! Don't mind us!" Xi Meili waved at them.

"Princess Xi, are you here to fight today? There is a line of people waiting to exchange techniques with you!" One of the judges there suddenly said to her.

"Hahaha! There's always a line!" Another judge laughed out loud.

One would expect a graceful princess like Xi Meili to avoid such things, but to one's surprise, Xi Meili loved to fight, and she was a regular at the Ancestral Dragon Temple.

Not only that, but she also accepts a fight from anyone no matter their background. Of course, she has yet to experience a single defeat in the Ancestral Dragon Temple.

"Sorry, but I am not here to fight today. I am just showing my new friends around the city." Xi Meili said.

And then she thought of something.

She turned to look at Yuan and said, "Unless you want to try it? You don't have to worry about getting hurt, and you get rewards if you win."

"What kind of rewards?" Yuan asked.

"From spirit stones to treasures, I guess. The spectators can bet on the match, and if you win, you get a portion of it. The fighters can even gamble their treasures in a match."

"They won't die even if I kill them, right?" Yuan wanted confirmation.

"Yes, you don't have to worry about hurting anyone." Xi Meili nodded.

"Okay, I will participate in a match." Yuan then agreed.

"Great! Oh, one more thing..." Xi Meili approached Yuan until her face was right beside his ears, and she whispered, "Don't tell them you're a human for now. Pretend you're a dragon."

"Okay." He nodded.

"Won't they recognize him by his smell like the guards did? They knew we were humans right away." Wang Xiuying suddenly said.

"Not everyone in this world knows the smell of humans. In fact, most of them have never seen humans before, so you'll just smell a little funny to them. The guards are a little special because they're trained to detect humans." Xi Meili said.

"S-Smell funny? I don't think I like how that sounds..." Wang Xiuying said.

"It's not a bad smell— at least I don't think so. I even think you smell pretty nice, especially Yuan. You have a unique smell that gives me a pleasant feeling whenever I smell it." Xi Meili said with a smile on her face.

"Judges! My friend here would like to participate in a match!" Xi Meili then said to one of the judges.

"Oh? Sure! Which stage would he like to fight in?" One of the judges then asked.

"What do you think, Yuan? Do you want to fight as a Spirit Grandmaster? You can even fight as a Spirit Master or Spirit Warrior."

"I'd like to fight as a Spirit Master," Yuan said, as he was more familiar with his own strength as a Spirit Master than a Spirit Grandmaster.

"Judge! Spirit Master!" Xi Meili then relayed his response to one of the judges.

"Go to stage number seven. He can go after this fight." The judge then said to her.

Although there were people in line, who would dare make the Dragon Princess wait? The fighters didn't voice any complaints either, as they were used to this favoritism for her.

"Thank you."

Thus, they began waiting for the fighters on the stage to finish their fight.

"Purple Dragon Fist!"

"Iron Dragon Claws!"

Boom!

A ripple of spiritual energy swept the area as these two fighters' techniques collided.

"Ah!"

One of the fighters flew off the arena a second later.

"Match ends! The winner is Long Yanjun!" The judge announced.

"Do you want to continue fighting?" The judge then asked the fighter.

"Who is my next opponent?" He asked.

The judge pointed to Yuan, who was standing beside Xi Meili.

"The Dragon Princess's friend."

"Oh? Princess Xi's friend? Now that's something you don't see every day." Long Yanjun smiled before nodding his head.

"Alright! I'll fight him as well!"

"Come on the stage, young man!" The judge said to Yuan.

Yuan nodded and approached the stage.

Many spectators that had been spectating the other stages suddenly left their stage to spectate Yuan's match, as they did not recognize him, and they were curious about his capabilities, especially since he was Xi Meili's friend.

"Does anyone recognize him? I don't think I have seen him before." One of the spectators asked out of curiosity.

"I don't recognize him either."

"Me neither."

"First time seeing him as well."

"Does nobody here know him? How is that possible?"

Although the Ancient Dragon City is as big as an entire continent, it was by no means a big place, especially when everyone could live for thousands of years with ease, so most of the people in this world already know each other one way or another.

Therefore, it was incredibly rare for someone to remain as a nobody, especially if that person is a friend of the Dragon Princess, one of the most recognized individuals in this world.

"What's your name? I'm Long Yanjun." The fighter on the stage introduced himself.

"You can call me Yuan," he responded.

"Yuan? I haven't heard of you before. Where did you come from?" Long Yanjun asked him.

"Uhhh... The Dragon Essence Temple?" Yuans said.

"Dragon Essence Temple? I have never heard of this place." Long Yanjun raised his eyebrows.

"Y-Yeah... It's a pretty small place so not many people know it. It's also in a secluded area very far away from this place." Yuan gave him an excuse, trying his best to act like he's from this world.

"I see... Well, best of luck to you." Long Yanjun clasped his hands and bowed to Yuan in a respectful manner.

"Yes, good luck to you as well." Yuan followed his movements and returned the bow.

Chapter 363 - Let Me Fight Him!

"I will assume that this is your first time here since I don't recognize you, so give me a minute to explain to you the rules." The judge said to him.

"One, you cannot use any treasures. Two, under any circumstances, if you leave the arena, it will be your loss. Anything else goes."

"Hm? Since I cannot use my treasures, will there be weapons provided to me? I usually use a sword or dagger." Yuan said.

"I don't mind if he uses his treasures." Long Yanjun suddenly said.

"Are you sure?" The judge asked him for confirmation.

"If that's what he's comfortable with, I don't mind. It wouldn't be fair to him if he cannot fight without his weapons."

The judge nodded and said, "Okay, you can use your treasure."

"Wait, you're going to be fighting me with your fists? But that wouldn't be fair at all." Yuan said.

Long Yanjun laughed and said, "Don't worry, my fists are my treasure. They won't lose to even Heaven-grade treasures."

"Even if you say that, it just doesn't feel right fighting someone barehanded with a weapon. It's okay, I will eventually have to learn how to fight without my weapons since I shouldn't rely on them too much." Yuan said, refusing to use his treasures.

"Are you sure?" Long Yanjun asked him, admiring his strong integrity.

"I am sure." Yuan nodded.

"Good! Then I shall let you have the first strike!" Long Yanjun said to him before standing there in a defensive position. "Go ahead. I won't attack you unless you strike!"

Yuan nodded, but he didn't immediately attack.

Instead, he pondered how he should fight Long Yanjun.

After a moment, he thought of something.

'I can simply use Qi Manifestation and use it as though it's my weapon!' He thought to himself.

"I'll be striking now," Yuan warned him since he was kind enough to give him the first strike.

"Go ahead." Long Yanjun said with a confident smile on his face.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan used Qi Manifestation and covered his fist with thick spiritual energy.

"What! How can you use Qi Manifestation at that level?!" Long Yanjun was shocked when he saw what Yuan was trying to do.

The spectators were also shocked.

Both Yuan and Long Yanjun have their cultivation limited to the first level of Spirit Master, and although they have seen geniuses who can use Qi Manifestation before Spirit Grandmaster, they were always around the peak of Spirit Master.

This is their first time seeing someone use Qi Manifestation at the first level!

"Heavens! How does he have the spiritual energy to use Qi Manifestation at the first level? This guy is a monster!"

"Where on earth did he come from? There's no way such a talented individual is a nobody!"

Meanwhile, Yuan used a movement technique to instantly close his distance with Long Yanjun.

"Fast!" Long Yanjun crossed his arms and prepared to block Yuan's strike.

Boom!

"Fuck!"

Long Yanjun cursed out loud as he was sent flying out of the stage.

Before Long Yanjun left the stage, both his arms had been completely crushed by Yuan's casual and even somewhat inexperienced punch, but after he left the stage, his injuries immediately healed, almost like his injury never happened in the first place.

Once he was outside the stage, Long Yanjun's peak Spirit Lord cultivation base returned, allowing him to regain control over his own body.

"What a powerful punch!" He looked at his arms that were trembling from shock.

He then turned to look at Yuan and clasped his hands together, "I had underestimated you. I'm sorry. It's my loss."

"He defeated Long Yanjun in a single strike?! Even though it was a free attack, it is still shocking! Long Yanjun has a 90 percent win rate with over a thousand victories and only a hundred losses!"

The spectators saw Yuan in a more serious light now.

"Do you wish to stay on the stage for another fight?" The judge asked him afterward.

"The fight ended too fast. I'd like to do another one." Yuan said.

"Okay. Then who would like to fight this young man next?" The judge looked at the spectators.

Immediately, over a dozen people raised their hands.

"I want to fight him!"

"No, let me fight him!"

"Pick me! Pick me!"

The judge looked at Yuan and asked him, "You can pick your fighter."

"Pick me, young man! I also use the sword!" One of the fighters there said, and he was emitting the aura of a peak Spirit King.

"Really?"

"Yes! Really! Look!"

This individual then retrieved a red sword that was emitting a profound aura that could only be emitted by Divine-grade treasures.

"Okay! Let's fight!" Yuan nodded with excitement.

Hearing Yuan's words, this middle-aged man with the red sword jumped onto the stage.

"My name is Xing Chongzhi!" The middle-aged man introduced himself with his hands clasped.

"Yuan."

"Then for this match, the both of you can use your treasures." The judge said.

"Xing Chongzhi is fighting next? Although he only has a win rate of 70 percent, all of his losses don't include the sword! When he wields his sword, his win rate is 100 percent!"

"This is going to be an interesting fight."

"Do you think Yuan will win?" Wang Xiuying asked Xi Meili as they watched from the background.

"I have never seen his sword skills so I cannot say. However, Xing Chongzhi is a renowned sword expert who learned Sword Aura when he was only 700 years old. He's definitely one of the best swordmasters in the Ancient Dragon City."

"700 years? What is this Sword Aura, and why does it take so long to learn?" Wang Xiuying asked.

"Sword Aura isn't something you can just learn, and you cannot learn it through normal means like other techniques because it's not really a technique. One can even go their whole life without learning Sword Aura if they're not talented enough or destined to." Xi Meili said.

"Wow... That sounds quite incredible." Wang Xiuying said as she looked at Yuan, wondering how he'll defeat someone who knows such a powerful skill.

Chapter 364 - Royal Family's Secret Child

"Take out your sword." Xing Chongzhi pointed his red sword at Yuan with a confident smile on his face.

Yuan nodded and retrieved his Empyrean Overlord, shocking the spectators.

"Is that...?"

"That's a Soul Weapon! He has a Soul Weapon!"

The spectators immediately recognized the Empyrean Overlord as a Soul Weapon despite its lack of aura— or perhaps that's how they knew it was a Soul Weapon right away.

"I didn't recognize it because of the chaotic situation at that time, but to think he has a Soul Weapon as well..." Xi Meili mumbled in a slightly surprised voice.

"As well? Does this mean you also have one?" Wang Xiuying asked her.

"Yes. It's our family heritage that was left behind by our Dragon Ancestor. It's a powerful spear that is rumored to have the capabilities to pierce even the heavens." Xi Meili nodded.

On the stage, after his initial surprise, Xing Chongzhi smiled and said, "A Soul Weapon, huh? I'm envious."

"Are the two of you ready?" The judge asked them.

"Ready when you are." Xing Chongzhi said to Yuan.

"I am ready as well."

"Then the match begins now!"

"I'm going to bet ten spirit stones on Xing Chongzhi!" One of the spectators suddenly said.

"I'll bet fifteen on that young man!"

"Fifty for Xing Chongzhi!"

"Twenty-five spirit stones for Xing Chongzhi!"

The spectators began shouting out their bets with most of them betting on Xing Chongzhi's victory, which wasn't too surprising due to his perfect win rate when he wields a sword.

Furthermore, Xing Chongzhi knew Sword Aura, something that could be used even as a Spirit Master.

"I will bet one thousand spirit stones on Yuan!" A clear voice suddenly resounded, causing the people to turn to look at this person who dared to bet such a large amount.

"Princess Xi? You think this young man is going to win?" One of them couldn't help but ask her.

"Not really. I'm just hoping for a miracle to happen," she said with a calm smile on her face.

Meanwhile, on the stage, Xing Chongzhi suddenly released his Sword Aura, filling the area with a domineering pressure.

The audience was immediately awed by Xing Chongzhi's Sword Aura.

"Wow! How long has it been since I last saw Xing Chongzhi's Sword Aura?"

"I have seen it many times now, but it still leaves me speechless."

"As expected of a swordmaster. Even though he's not directing the Sword Aura at me, I can still feel as though there are invisible swords surrounding me!"

"Sword Aura, huh?" Yuan was pleasantly surprised that his opponent knew Sword Aura too!

"You're not the only one who can use Sword Aura!" Yuan said with a smile on his face before releasing his own Sword Aura, immediately colliding with Xing Chongzhi's Sword Aura.

"What! Impossible!"

The first to express her shock and disbelief was Xi Meili.

If she remembers correctly, Yuan mentioned that he was only 18 years old! How could someone comprehend Sword Aura at such a young age?!

It took Xing Chongzhi 700 years to understand Sword Aura and he was considered a top genius with the sword!

"I really don't know what to say besides... As expected from the one who released all nine pillars of light." Xi Meili mumbled in a low voice.

Meanwhile, the other spectators were shocked speechless, and they could feel invisible swords touching their neck after Yuan released his Sword Aura, which was clearly more devastating than Xing Chongzhi's Sword Aura.

On the stage, Xing Chongzhi stared at Yuan with a gawking look on his face, looking like he was looking at ghosts for the first time in his life.

"H-How old are you, again?" Xing Chongzhi decided to ask him, completely forgetting about their match.

"I'm eighteen years old," Yuan responded.

"E-Eighteen years old... A-And when did you learn Sword Aura?"

"A little over a week ago, I guess," Yuan said.

"Y-You learned Sword Aura a week ago? And it's already this powerful?" Xing Chongzhi's body trembled after hearing Yuan's words.

It was at this moment he realized that his 100 percent win rate was in jeopardy. How could he possibly fight against someone who has managed to learn Sword Aura a few hundred years faster than he did? Not to mention Yuan's Sword Aura was already stronger than his own despite knowing it for only a mere week, whilst he has known Sword Aura for many centuries.

'I-It's okay. His Sword Aura may be more powerful than mine, but when it comes to techniques, I should still be superior!' Xing Chongzhi thought to himself.

Indeed, Xing Chongzhi had guessed correctly. Whilst Yuan was a monster when it comes to comprehension, he was still too young and inexperienced compared to Xing Chongzhi, who has thousands of years of experience under his belt.

Therefore, while Yuan was unrivaled in terms of raw strength, his technique was a bit lacking.

"Here I come!" Xing Chongzhi immediately used his movement technique to close the distance whilst swinging the red sword in his grasp in a swift and precise manner.

Yuan also used his movement technique to dodge the incoming strike before retaliating with the Empyrean Overlord.

[Bloody Sword Strike!]

Yuan swung the massive sword as though it was as light as a feather.

'I cannot block that with my sword! He'll send me flying!' Xing Chongzhi could instinctively tell that he wouldn't be able to withstand the might of Yuan's sword and didn't even bother to block it, using his effort to dodge it instead.

CLANG!

The stage shook when Yuan's sword slammed onto it, and to his surprise, there was not a single dent on the platform.

'What is this platform made of?! It's like steel!' Yuan cried inwardly, feeling his entire body tremble from the impact, even almost losing grip on his sword.

Xing Chongzhi noticed that this was his chance to strike and immediately went for Yuan's neck.

'Oh!'

When Yuan saw Xing Chongzhi suddenly appear in front of him with the red sword already in motion and heading towards his head, he subconsciously activated Dragon's Gaze at its full power, taking Xing Chongzhi by surprise and instantly halting his movements.

Seeing this, Yuan ignored the numbing sensation in his arms and swung the Empyrean Overlord, separating Xing Chongzhi's head from his body in a split second.

The audience gasped in shock after they witnessed this unexpected outcome. However, what surprised them the most was the technique Yuan had just used, as it caused their dragon bloodlines to react in a manner that was similar to awe and reverence.

"I-Impossible! How does he know that technique?!" Xi Meili exclaimed in a shocked voice after seeing Yuan use Dragon's Gaze.

The Dragon's Gaze is one of the most powerful techniques for dragons! However, it's not a technique that could be learned just by any dragons! In fact, only dragons of royal blood can learn this technique!

"D-Did he just use Dragon's Gaze?" The other people there were also in disbelief.

"I think he did..."

"He's from the Royal Family? But I have never seen him before! Don't tell me that he's the Royal Family's secret child!"

The audience immediately began to speculate about Yuan's background.

A few moments after Yuan killed Xing Chongzhi, he reappeared outside the stage still with a dazed look on his face, almost like he was still under the effects of the Dragon's Gaze.

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Chapter 365 - Human

"Xing Chongzhi, are you okay?" The judge for stage 7 patted him on the shoulders when he showed no response even many moments after leaving the stage.

"W-What happened to me just now? Why am I standing outside the stage?" Xing Chongzhi finally snapped out of his daze and proceeded to look around with a puzzled look on his face, clearly unaware of what had just occurred.

"You were killed by the young man." The judge revealed to him.

"What! How is that possible?! I was pretty sure I had him at that moment!" Xing Chongzhi expressed disbelief. In his mind, he'd successfully connected his strike, killing Yuan.

Nobody there blamed him for his reaction, as it was a normal response for someone who'd just experienced the Dragon's Gaze at point-blank.

The judge shook his head and began explaining everything that had happened, shocking him even further.

"Dragon's Gaze?! What?!" Xing Chongzhi turned to look at Yuan, who was still standing on the stage, with a flabbergasted look on his face.

"You are part of the Royal Family?!" Xing Chongzhi asked him, as everyone knew that only the Royal Family could learn such a profound technique.

"No?" Yuan said.

"You're not? Then how did you learn the Dragon's Gaze? That's something only the Royal Family can learn!" Xing Chongzhi and the other spectators only became more puzzled after hearing his words.

However, before Yuan could respond, Xi Meili suddenly said, "He's from the Royal Family."

"Eh?"

Both Yuan and Xing Chongzhi turned to look at Xi Meili, and on Yuan's face was a surprised look. Since when did he become part of the Royal Family?

'Yuan, just follow along with me for now. I'll explain to you later.'

Xi Meili's voice suddenly resounded inside Yuan's head.

Yuan nodded while looking at her before clearing his throat and speaking out loud, "T-That's right. I am actually from the Royal Family. I wasn't sure whether I should reveal my identity or not before..."

The spectators gasped in shock after learning this. To think the Royal Family had a third child!

"He may be from the Royal Family, but he isn't related to our Royal Family in the way you're thinking." Xi Meili suddenly said, clearly that misunderstanding.

"What?"

The spectators' thoughts went wild with theories, and they could only think of one thing after pondering for some time— that Yuan had married into the Royal Family! In other words, he was Xi Meili's husband!

"C-Congratulations, Princess Xi!" The people there suddenly bowed to her.

"Eh?" Xi Meili raised her eyebrows, wondering what they were thinking.

"You have finally found your partner after 10 thousand years! Congratulations!"

The spectators congratulated her again.

"What?!" Xi Meili's eyes widened with shock. How in heaven's name did they get to that conclusion?

"That's wrong! He's not my husband! We're just friends!" Xi Meili refuted their claims with a flushed face.

And she continued, "Furthermore, he's a human!"

"W-Wait... What? He's a human? How is that possible?" Everybody there turned to look at Yuan with shocked looks on their faces.

How the hell did a human appear in their Ancient Dragon City? And how could a human belong to the Royal Family? Nothing about his background made sense!

"His situation is a complicated one. Do you guys remember the nine pillars of light that occurred not long ago? He was the one who released all pillars of light and summoned the Dragon Ancestor." Xi Meili revealed to them the truth.

"What! H-He's the one who was behind that?! A mere human?!"

A commotion quickly started in the Ancestral Dragon Temple.

"Uhhh..." Yuan wasn't sure what was happening, so he said, "Are we still fighting?"

The judge snapped out of his daze and said, "R-Right! Does anyone still want to fight him?!"

The spectators exchanged glances with each other.

After a moment of complete silence, a dozen people raised their hands at once and said, "I want to fight him even more now! I have never fought a

human before!"

"Me too! Let me fight him!"

Since there were so many people that wanted to fight Yuan, the judge decided to ask him again.

"I'll fight until I can no longer fight," Yuan said.

"Great! Then let's start with you!" The judge randomly pointed to one of the spectators with his arms raised.

A moment later, the fighter appeared on the stage with a lance in his grasp.

'What kind of weapon is that? It looks like a spear, yet the head looks slightly different.' Yuan wondered to himself as he held the Empyrean Overlord in front of him.

The fight started after the judge left the stage.

[Bloody Sword Strike!]

[Dragon Lance!]

Ding!

The fighter could feel his arms shaking violently after their weapons collided.

'What a powerful attack! It feels like I am fighting against a mountain!' The fighter cried inwardly as he slid backward on the stage until he was at the edge of the stage.

'That was close! I shouldn't fight him head-on! He's too powerful!' With that in mind, the fighter started to dodge all of Yuan's attacks while retaliating with his lance that had an advantage in range due to the long handle.

However, even with the range advantage, the fighter was unable to land a single hit on Yuan due to his profound movement technique.

"What kind of movement technique is he using?! He's leaving a trail of flames as he moves, and I cannot predict his movements at all!"

"It's probably some profound human movement technique we have never heard about before."

The spectators were mesmerized by Yuan's movement techniques, completely unaware that he'd learned it from a phoenix.

After a few minutes of fighting back and forth, Yuan finally managed to defeat the fighter after taking him by surprise with his movement technique that had suddenly improved drastically, almost as if he had a breakthrough in the middle of the battle.

[Your comprehension for 'Vermilion Phoenix Dominating the Heavens' has reached a new level]

[Vermilion Phoenix Dominating the Heavens Mastery Level (1) → (2)]

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Chapter 366 - Staring Contest

After defeating the fighter with the lance, Yuan proceeded to fight the other participants that wanted to fight him, and because of his profound movement technique that only got more ridiculously hard to predict after his skill had reached a new level, none of his opponents was able to even touch his shadow, leading to Yuan's victory inevitably.

"Is there anyone else that would like to fight me?" Yuan asked with his body soaked in sweat as he defeated his 30th opponent in a row, setting a new record at the Ancestral Dragon Temple.

"Fuck! Is he really human? Where does he get his stamina from?"

The dragons there refused to believe Yuan was a human. In their minds, humans are weak and fragile existence that cannot hold a candle against dragons, yet it was the complete opposite with Yuan.

"Where did this human come from, anyway?"

The dragons were filled with questions but had no answers, and they didn't want to stick their noses into the Royal Family's business too much.

A few moments went by without anyone appearing on the stage.

"I guess this is it," Yuan said, feeling very satisfied, as he'd gained a lot of experience through so many battles just now.

However, right as he prepared to leave the stage, someone said, "I'll fight you next!"

A figure suddenly jumped onto the stage from afar and stood before Yuan with a bright smile on her face.

"Xi Meili?" Yuan raised his eyebrows when he saw the dragon princess standing on the stage. She wants to fight him as well?

"Look! Princess Xi wants to fight him next!"

"Ohhh! This is going to be exciting!"

The spectators were immediately filled with anticipation after seeing this matchup. By now, pretty much everybody in the Ancestral Dragon Temple was watching their fight, leaving the other stages completely empty.

"I just couldn't hold my excitement back after seeing you fight and defeat so many people, so I decided to fight you as well, Yuan. I hope you don't mind." Xi Meili said to him.

"I don't mind." Yuan nodded.

"Thank you, Yuan. However, I will admit that I won't be able to defeat you in a normal fight, so let's do something different in this match." Xi Meili then said.

"Something different? What do you have in mind?" Yuan tilted his head slightly.

"Dragon's Gaze. We're going to see which of us can use Dragon's Gaze better. Like a staring contest. How does that sound?" She suggested.

"You can use the Dragon's Gaze as well?" Yuan looked at her with wide eyes, as this was a pleasant surprise.

"Of course. The Dragon's Gaze is a technique taught to everybody in the Royal Family." Xi Meili nodded, and she continued. "It is one of the most ancient techniques out there for our Dragon Race, and it was created during the primordial era."

"I know this may be unfair to you, who has only lived for 18 years while I have almost 10 thousand years of experience with the technique, but I really want to see how powerful your Dragon Gaze is."

"I don't mind it. I also want to see your Dragon's Gaze." Yuan nodded with a smile on his face.

"Great! Then at the count to three, we'll both use Dragon's Gaze simultaneously. Whoever is overwhelmed first will be the loser. Judge, you will do the counting." Xi Meili said.

"I understand, Princess Xi."

"Ready when you are, Yuan."

"I am ready."

The judge began his count to three once both of them were ready.

"One... two... three!"

On three, both Yuan and Xi Meili activated Dragon's Gaze, and their eyes immediately glowed gold.

Whoosh!

A massive pressure suddenly enveloped the place, causing the spectators to take steps back and away from the stage.

"Not bad, Yuan." Xi Meili said with a smile on her face as she stared at Yuan directly into his eyes.

"However, this isn't my full power."

Xi Meili increased the intensity of her Dragon's Gaze, and the pressure grew stronger.

Yuan could immediately feel goosebumps appearing all over his body, yet there was a smile of excitement on his face.

"I am also just getting started!"

Yuan said as his golden eyes glowed more brightly.

The spectators took a couple more steps back.

"Hahaha! Not bad! Not bad at all, Yuan!"

Xi Meili suddenly started moving, slowly approaching Yuan with small steps.

The world around Yuan suddenly grew darker and darker, and Yuan felt like cowering as Xi Meili approached him, but he'd managed to fight back his fear.

Then, he also started to move forward!

Xi Meili was shocked inwardly when Yuan did the exact opposite of what she expected.

'What a powerful mental strength he has! He actually dares to approach me even though he's clearly afraid!'

Xi Meili's blood that had been calm for many thousand years suddenly began boiling with excitement! She wanted to see the limit of this human!

The two of them continued to walk closer to each other, quickly closing their distance.

A few moments later, they both stood directly in front of each other with their faces only a couple of inches away from each other.

The spectators swallowed nervously when they saw this. Even though they were not clashing treasures or displaying flashy techniques, their match was more exciting and nerve-wracking than any of the matches that had occurred today!

"Yuan, if you can defeat me, I'll consider marrying you— No, I'll marry you." Xi Meili suddenly said with a relaxed smile on her face, shocking the spectators.

However, Yuan was too focused on resisting her Dragon's Gaze to hear her words.

After standing so close to each other for about a minute, blood could be seen flowing from Yuan's nose, clearly reaching his limit.

Xi Meili didn't say anything when she saw this and continued to increase the strength of her Dragon's Gaze.

A few moments later, blood flowed from Yuan's eyes, looking like he was crying blood.

Yuan could feel pain all over his body— like it was being crushed by an unrivaled force. Despite this, he refused to give up and continued to fight Xi Meili's Dragon's Gaze with his Dragon's Gaze.

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Chapter 367 - Returning To The Dragon Palace

Cough

After resisting Xi Meili's Dragon's Gaze for another minute, Yuan suddenly turned his head to the side and coughed up a mouthful of blood before closing his eyes and losing consciousness.

When she saw Yuan's body beginning to fall, Xi Meili quickly used her slender arms to catch his body, hugging his body afterward so that he didn't fall.

"Yuan!" Wang Xiuying rushed onto the stage with a worried look on her face.

"He's okay. He only sustained minor internal injuries and lost consciousness due to the tremendous stress his mind had endured. His injuries will heal once he leaves the stage, but he'll probably remain unconscious for a little bit longer." Xi Meili said to Wang Xiuying to calm her down.

Xi Meili then carried Yuan like a princess and said, "I'll cut our tour today short and bring him back to the Dragon Palace with me for now."

"Thank you all for your time today." Xi Meili said to the spectators and the fighters before flying away while carrying Yuan in her arms and Wang Xiuying with Qi Manifestation.

The people in the Ancestral Dragon Temple remained still and silent for a good moment even after Xi Meili and the others left.

Sometime later, someone said, "I'm exhausted— even though I didn't fight anyone today. I think I'll go home for today."

Once one person spoke, the others also began snapping out of their daze.

"You're right. I need some good rest after today..."

"Me too."

Thus, everyone left the Ancestral Dragon Temple shortly after, leaving the Ancestral Dragon Temple completely empty for the rest of the day, which was an extremely rare sight.

On their way back to the Dragon Palace, Xi Meili stared at Yuan's peaceful sleeping face their entire way there with a profound look on her face, looking like she was in deep thoughts.

"Even though I am well aware that he'd managed to reveal all nine pillars of light, his talents still shock me." Xi Meili mumbled in a low voice.

"Just what is his background? It's simply unbelievable that someone like him exists in the Lower Heavens."

"Do you have any ideas?" Xi Meili turned to ask Wang Xiuying.

Wang Xiuying shrugged and said, "He's as much of a mystery to me as he is to you. I also have no idea about his identity. We encountered each other by chance, and I have been following him since then out of curiosity."

"I see... Well, I won't dive any deeper than this."

Sometime later, they returned to the Dragon Palace.

"What happened?! Who did this to him?!" The Dragon Emperor was immediately enraged when he saw Xi Meili bring back Yuan in such a state, looking like he was prepared to kill someone.

"Well... I did this to him..." Xi Meili said with a somewhat blushing look on her face.

"What? You? Why? What happened?" The Dragon Emperor was greatly taken aback when he learned that it was his own daughter that had injured Yuan!

"Calm down, father. Let me explain." Xi Meili said, and she proceeded to explain to him the situation and how everything occurred.

"I had a match with him, and I wanted to test his limits..."

After explaining everything to the Dragon Emperor, he sat down with a look of disbelief on his face.

"He also knows Dragon's Gaze? How is that possible?" The Dragon Emperor mumbled.

"Anyways, I am going to let Yuan rest in his room for now." Xi Meili said.

Sometime later, Xi Meili placed Yuan on the bed before returning to the Dragon Emperor's side.

"Father, I have a question." Xi Meili said to him with a serious look on her face.

"What is it?" He looked at her with raised eyebrows, as she rarely shows such an expression.

"What do you think of a dragon and a human being together?" Xi Meili asked.

"Huh? What do you mean by that?" The Dragon Emperor didn't immediately comprehend her question and asked her.

"Marriage. What do you think of a dragon marrying a human?" Xi Meili asked again, this time making it crystal clear.

"Marriage? What kind of question is this— Wait... Don't tell me you're..." The Dragon Emperor's eyes widened with shock when he realized her reason for asking this question.

"D-Don't tell me you're interested in him?" He asked for confirmation.

Xi Meili nodded and said, "I am considering it."

"What made you pick him?" The Dragon Emperor asked her with a profound frown on his face, yet he didn't immediately refuse.

"Is it because of his talent? His strength? Or is it just because of the fact that he's a human?"

"A little bit of everything," she replied with a slight smile on her face.

"In terms of talent, he's above everyone in this world. Although his experience is somewhat lacking, he's definitely a fast learner. Furthermore, he has this unique aura around him— this charisma that is quite attractive. Oh, he's also very handsome." Xi Meili said.

"You're really serious about this, aren't you?" The Dragon Emperor said with a pondering look on his face.

Xi Meili nodded. "I sat through countless arranged marriages, meeting countless men over the last few thousand years, but alas, none of them could make my blood boil the way Yuan did today on the stage."

"I understand that he appears to be an excellent partner, but you just met him not long ago... You're barely acquainted, much less friends." The Dragon Emperor said.

"And how is that any different from the people you've arranged for me, huh? I don't even know them at all!" Xi Meili refuted.

"Uhh..." The Dragon Emperor was rendered speechless after hearing her words. Indeed, his logic was flawed.

After pondering for a moment, he said, "You're right about that. However, he's not from our world, and he won't remain here forever. Once we find a way to help them return to where they came from, that'll be the end of you and him."

"..."

It was Xi Meili's turn to become silent now, as her father was right about this one. Yuan won't be here forever, which will make their relationship complicated if not impossible.

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Chapter 368 - First Defeat

"Well... If he cannot stay here, how about I just follow him outside?" Xi Meili suddenly suggested. "I have always been interested in the outside world, anyway."

"You want to go outside? Are you crazy? The humans will hunt you for your blood! It's too dangerous!" The Dragon Emperor immediately refused.

"That's only what our ancestors taught us, but they have also never been to the outside world before. If there are humans like Yuan and Wang Xiuying outside, I don't think it'll be that bad."

After a moment of silence, the Dragon Emperor said, "Unfortunately, that's impossible— not because I don't want to let you go outside with him. Your cultivation base is simply too high to follow him back to the Lower Heavens, where Spirit Grandmaster is the limit."

"You're simply asking to be punished by the heavens for doing so."

"Oh, right... He's from the Lower Heavens..." Xi Meili sighed, completely forgetting about that for a second.

Meanwhile, inside Yuan's room, Wang Xiuying checked his pulses just to make sure he was okay.

'Seeing him sleep like this... he really reminds me of Yu Tian...' Wang Xiuying said as she stared at Yuan's sleeping face with a somewhat dazed gaze.

The more she looked at Yuan, the more she felt like she had seen him before.

"Nnn..." Yuan suddenly opened his eyes slowly.

"Where am I...?" he mumbled in a dazed voice.

"Oh, you're awake, Yuan. We're at the Dragon Palace in your room. Xi Meili took us back after you fell unconscious during the match." Wang Xiuying explained to him what had happened.

"I see... So I lost the match, huh?" A smile on Yuan's face as he realized the situation.

"This was my first time losing a fight," he sighed in a somewhat bitter voice.

Losing felt much worse than he'd expected, especially since it's his first defeat.

"I wouldn't really call that a fight... And your opponent has 10 thousand years more experience than you. It's only obvious that you wouldn't be able to defeat her no matter your talents." Wang Xiuying said, trying to comfort him.

"I guess you're right." Yuan nodded.

"Wait right here. I'll go to Xi Meili to let her know that you're awake." Wang Xiuying said before leaving the room for a few minutes.

"Xi Meili... she was very strong— stronger than anyone I have ever fought before," Yuan mumbled as he stared at the ceiling with a dazed look on his face.

Sometime later, Wang Xiuying returned with Xi Meili and the Dragon Emperor.

"Are you okay, Yuan? Are you hurt anywhere?" Xi Meili asked him.

"I am fine," he said.

"Anyways, you really surprised me, Yuan. You're only 18 years old, yet your comprehension for the Dragon's Gaze is already as strong as mine!" Xi Meili immediately praised him afterward.

A bittersweet smile appeared on Yuan's face.

"As strong? That's not true. I was completely defeated by your Dragon's Gaze."

"Yuan, if you don't mind me asking, where did you learn the Dragon's Gaze? And how long has it been since you learned it? The Dragon's Gaze is a secret technique only available to the Royal Family." The Dragon Emperor suddenly asked him.

"Oh, I learned it from the Great One. And it was probably around a month ago when I learned it," he said.

"The Great One?!" The Dragon Emperor exclaimed.

"One month?!" Xi Meili was shocked for a different reason.

To think Yuan could comprehend the Dragon's Gaze to such an extent in a mere month whilst it took her thousands of years to reach her current level! The disparity was too large!

"Can you tell me more about it? How did you learn it from the Great One?" The Dragon Emperor continued to ask.

Yuan nodded and explained to him how he learned it from the Tablet of Comprehension, where he met the illusion of the Great One.

"I understand it, but I cannot believe it... The Great One is teaching the secret technique to random people? Just what is he thinking?" The Dragon Emperor could feel a headache coming.

It would be a disaster if their secret technique was revealed to the public, but luckily for them, according to Yuan, only two people have learned the Dragon's Gaze, and he was one of them.

"Is it really that bad if an outsider learns the technique?" Yuan couldn't help but ask them.

The Dragon Emperor nodded and said, "Since ancient times, only the Royal Family can use the Dragon's Gaze, and it's already well-established that whoever learns the Dragon's Gaze is royalty in the Dragon Race. If someone who isn't part of the Royal Family learns this technique, it'll create massive confusion and chaos amongst us— the dragons."

"There are multiple Royal Families out there, and we're just one of many. Although we don't really care that much about an outsider learning the technique since we're in this isolated world, the other Royal Families in the upper heavens may not react so kindly to an outsider learning their technique, something they are extremely proud of."

Xi Meili added, "They consider the technique as sacred as their bloodline, as both of them were given to them by the Dragon Ancestor."

"In other words, you shouldn't use your Dragon's Gaze so lightly— especially in front of other dragons."

"I see... I didn't know about this since the Great One never told me about it when I learned the technique..." Yuan said.

"Anyways, there's nothing we can do about it now that you've learned the technique. Just make sure you're not around dragons when you use that technique, as it will definitely cause misunderstandings." The Dragon Emperor said to him.

"I understand." Yuan nodded.

"Of course, if you marry someone from the Royal Family, you'll be considered royalty, allowing you to use the technique as much as you wish." Xi Meili suddenly said, clearly suggesting something here.

Of course, Yuan was too innocent to pick up the hint and said, "Marriage? As in husband and wife? But I don't think it's right to marry someone just to use a technique."

Xi Meili smiled after hearing his words, "I think so too."

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Chapter 369 - Dragon Meat Skewer

"Anyways, it's not like we're telling you to never use the Dragon's Gaze ever again. Just make sure you're very careful when using it, as it will definitely offend the other Royal Families if they learn that an outsider had learned their sacred technique," said the Dragon Emperor a few moments later.

"I understand. I will be careful." Yuan nodded.

"Now, regarding the teleport formation that will bring you back to the Lower Heavens, I have found a way, but we will need some time to prepare." The Dragon Emperor suddenly said.

"Does this mean we can return to our own place? This is great news!" Wang Xiuying quickly said.

"Yes. However, it will still take around a week."

"That's fine. As long as we return before the event ends." Yuan said.

Sometime later, the Dragon Emperor left the room and returned to prepare for their departure.

"What do you want to do now?" Xi Meili asked them afterward.

"Do you still want to look around the city? Or do you want to do something else?"

"I still want to look around," Yuan said.

"Okay, but you only have one week, so we won't be able to see much. Maybe you'll come back next time for much longer. At that time, I will

show you around the entire Ancient Dragon City." Xi Meili said to him.

"Even if I want to come back, how can I do that?" Yuan asked.

"I don't know, but if you've already managed to come here once, you'll definitely find yourself here a second time. I believe in fate, and if you're fated to return, you'll definitely return. If that happens..." A mysterious smile appeared on her face.

Yuan nodded, "Okay."

"Go get some more rest. We'll go back to touring the city tomorrow morning."

Xi Meili also left the room shortly after, meeting her father at the teleport formation outside the Ancient Dragon City.

"I have decided, father." Xi Meili said to him.

"On what?" He raised his eyebrows.

"I won't marry Yuan now. However, if he manages to return to this world for a second time, I will marry him." Xi Meili said.

"What kind of decision is that? You'll marry him if he returns for a second time? Do you really think he'll be able to return here for a second time? If he was destined to come here before, he's already fulfilled his fate in this world, which means he no longer has a reason to return here." The Dragon Emperor said.

"If fate allows it, he will definitely return. I also have this feeling that this won't be my last time seeing him." Xi Meili said with a confident smile on her pretty face.

"Even if he is fated to return in the future, who knows when that will be. It could be ten years from now. It can even be ten thousand years from now. We will never know." The Dragon Emperor said.

"So what? We can live up to tens of thousands of years with ease because of our bloodline."

The Dragon Emperor shook his head in a defeated manner.

"Do as you wish. You'll probably forget about him in a few hundred years, anyway." The Dragon Emperor shrugged.

"Do you want to make a bet with me on that, father?" Xi Meili suddenly asked him.

"A bet? Interesting. Tell me more." He said.

"One thousand years— if he doesn't return in one thousand years, I'll marry someone on your terms." Xi Meili then said.

"Y-You're serious about this?" The Dragon Emperor looked at her with wide eyes.

"Does it look like I am joking with you, father?" Xi Meili responded with a solemn look on her face.

"And if he returns before the time limit of one thousand years, I will have to let you marry him without any complaints, right?" The Dragon Emperor then spoke.

Xi Meili nodded, "That's right."

"Very well. I will accept your bet."

"The countdown will start once he leaves this world. Is that okay?" Xi Meili asked.

"I am fine with that."

"Great! Then it's decided!" Xi Meili then turned around and returned to the Dragon Palace with a cheerful aura around her, leaving the Dragon Emperor speechless.

"She really likes him, huh?" The Dragon Emperor shook his head with a bittersweet smile on his face before returning to focus on the teleport formation.

The next day, after eating the breakfast cooked by Meixiu, Yuan went into the game to have his second breakfast for the day with the Royal Family.

"Are you two ready for another day in the city?" Xi Meili asked them with an energetic aura around her.

"I am!" Yuan responded with a similar aura around him.

"Yes." Wang Xiuying also nodded, albeit a little less excited when compared to Yuan.

Thus, Xi Meili brought them around the city again. However, she didn't bring them towards the Ancestral Dragon Temple this time.

Instead, she brought them to multiple restaurants, showing off their dragon's cuisine, as she knew how much Yuan loved food.

"This is our famous Dragon Meat Skewer! Try it!" Xi Meili handed each of them a skewer.

"D-Dragon Meat?" Both Yuan and Wang Xiuying looked at her with wide eyes.

Isn't this considered cannibalism if they eat their own kind?

Xi Meili noticed their weird gazes and laughed, "Don't worry, it's not actually 'dragon' meat. I mean it is, but it's not the type you're thinking of."

"Oh..."

They took a bite a moment later.

"Wow! This is so delicious!" Yuan immediately claimed, feeling the meat melt in his mouth before exploding with flavor and spiritual energy.

"Wow, the texture is heavenly. It doesn't feel like I am eating meat at all! I wonder if this is what it would be like eating clouds if we could eat them!" Wang Xiuying said as she finished the entire skewer in just a few seconds.

"Can I have some more?" She then asked.

"Me too! I also want some more!" Yuan said.

"Are you sure? We finished breakfast not long ago." Xi Meili chuckled before asking for a couple more skewers.

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Chapter 370 - Spirit Stone Cave

"Here ya go, Princess Xi. These are on me." The man selling these skewers said to her.

After handing the skewers to Yuan and Wang Xiuying, Xi Meili handed a spirit stone to the man and said, "Don't worry about it. My friends enjoyed it, so I will pay for it. You can keep the change as well."

"Thank you very much, Princess Xi!" The man gladly accepted the spirit stone.

After eating the skewers in a few minutes, Wang Xiuying said, "That pretty stone you just gave the man as payment, it's called a spirit stone, right? I have seen them before, but I never understood them. Just where do people obtain them? Or are they like treasures, something you find naturally in the wild?"

"You don't know where spirit stones come from? Hehe... Then I know exactly where to bring you tomorrow!" Xi Meili said with a smile on her face.

"As for your question, I shall wait until tomorrow to answer it. For now, let's just continue what we're doing."

Wang Xiuying nodded, but her curiosity peaked.

Thus, Xi Meili continued to show them restaurants and different foods.

By the end of the day, they had eaten so much that dinner wasn't necessary.

In the real world, Yuan asked Meixiu, "What are the other participants doing now?"

"The same as usual. They're trying to reach the Mystic Pagoda while improving their cultivation at the same time. Some people have reached the place, but none of them have been able to open it." Meixiu said.

And she continued, "In fact, the participants that have arrived at the place seemed to have stopped fighting each other to try and open the Mystic Pagoda together."

"So they're working together to open the Mystic Pagoda, huh? Even though I somehow managed to open it, I still don't understand how—"

Yuan suddenly stopped speaking as he realized something.

"Wait a second... The demons said the Empyrean Overlord used to belong to the Lord, who is the master of the Mystic Realm and the Mystic Pagoda. Maybe that's the key to opening the Mystic Pagoda?"

"Hmm... That does make sense." Meixiu said.

"Anyways, I should be returning to the Mystic Realm soon. The Dragon Emperor found a way for us to return, but it'll take at least a week."

The following morning, after breakfast, Meixiu said, "Doctor Wang has sent me the menu. I will be going shopping in a bit."

"Oh? What's on the menu?" Yuan then asked.

"Doctor Wang told me to keep it a surprise for you," she said.

Yuan smiled and said, "I can't wait."

Sometime later, Yuan entered the game whilst Meixiu dressed up casually before going outside.

Luckily for Meixiu, there was a large supermarket only a couple of blocks from their apartment, making shopping easy and convenient.

An hour later, she returned to the apartment.

Meanwhile, inside the game, Yuan and Wang Xiuying followed Xi Meili.

"So, to answer your question from yesterday, there are a couple of ways spirit stones are created." Xi Meili said as she escorted them to this isolated area.

"One, spirit stones can be created naturally like minerals and gems."

Xi Meili pointed to the cave in front of them and continued, "That is a Spirit Stone Cave, where spirit stones can be mined. This is the most common way people get their spirit stones. Normal people cannot access this area, but because my family owns the Spirit Stone Cave, I can show you the inside in a moment."

"Another method is to create them by yourself, but this method is incredibly uncommon and almost nobody does it."

"W-Wait a second... Create them by ourselves? Does this mean we can also make spirit stones?" Wang Xiuying asked.

"That's right. Cultivators can make their own spirit stones." Xi Meili nodded.

"What! That means unlimited money! Why is this method uncommon? It should be the most common!"

Wang Xiuying exclaimed. After all, who wouldn't want to be able to make their own money?! That's a no-brainer!

Xi Meili chuckled and said, "Because it requires a tremendous amount of spiritual energy and effort to make even a single spirit stone, and cultivators would rather use that energy and time to increase their cultivation."

"How much effort and time are we talking about?" Wang Xiuying then asked.

"Let's see... As a Spirit Warrior, it'll probably take you a couple of weeks to create a single spirit stone, and during these few weeks, you would not be able to progress your cultivation because you'll be using all of your

spiritual energy to create the spirit stone. Do you understand why it's such an uncommon practice?" Xi Meili said.

"I see... but what about the cultivators at the top? Surely, they can make spirit stones much faster."

"They can. In fact, a Spirit Grandmaster can make one spirit stone a day, but like I'd already said, it's not worth it, as they'd rather use that time and energy on improving their cultivation."

Yuan then said, "If I remember correctly, a single spirit stone is worth about 10,000 gold. Although that may seem like a lot to us, for a Spirit Grandmaster, that's probably nothing, but I could be wrong."

"No, you're right." Xi Meili said.

"A single spirit stone may be worth a lot in the hands of a mortal, but for a cultivator at that level, it's worth nothing, as the resources they need to improve their cultivation are worth tens of thousands of spirit stones if not hundreds of thousands of spirit stones."

"Do you understand now?" Xi Meili asked Wang Xiuying.

She nodded, "Yes, I understand. Thank you for the explanation."

"Great! Then let me show you inside the Spirit Stone Cave. Follow me." Xi Meili said to them.

"Greetings, Princess Xi." The guards standing in front of the Spirit Stone cave greeted her, and they were both emitting the power of a Spirit King.

"Hello. I would like to show my friends around the Spirit Stone Cave since they have never seen it before. I hope you don't mind." Xi Meili said to them.

"Of course not. Please, take as much time as you need." The guards opened the doors for her with smiles on their faces.

Chapter 371 - Beef Stew

"Follow me." Xi Meili said to the two of them before walking into the cave that was brightly lit despite having no obvious sources of light, almost like the walls themselves were glowing.

The cave was incredibly long, as they'd walked for over ten minutes without seeing anything.

"How deep is this cave?" Wang Xiuying couldn't help but ask.

"A few thousand miles, I guess," she casually responded.

"What?! That's incredibly long! How is that even possible?"

"Do not underestimate Spirit Stone Caves. Each of them is incredibly spacious but only contains a few hundred thousand spirit stones, and if you mine them all, it will require 100 years for them to return." Xi Meili said.

"Did you realize that the spiritual energy in here is vastly different from the outside? This is a special type of spiritual energy that gives birth to spirit stones. If you ever come across this kind of spiritual energy, make sure to look around, as there will be a Spirit Stone Cave nearby, and those are worth a fortune, so make sure you remember this feeling." Xi Meili said to them.

Wang Xiuying and Yuan nodded before engraving this spiritual energy into their heart. Hopefully, they'll run into a Spirit Stone Cave of their own one day.

About half an hour later, they could finally see some spirit stones, and they were sticking out of the wall like crystals.

"Wow, so this is what spirit stones look like in nature... How cool."

Both Yuan and Wang Xiuying stared at them as though they were fascinated.

"We make sure to leave some behind so that they can regrow in the future."

"They can regrow?" They looked at her with raised eyebrows.

Xi Meili nodded and said, "As long as we don't mine everything, they will eventually grow back. Though, that will take at least 100 years."

"Anyways, this is the furthest we should go. But it's not because we cannot be there. It's simply because there won't be anything to see unless we travel a few hundred miles out, which could take hours, and I don't want to waste your time." Xi Meili said.

And she continued, "If you really want to see it, just imagine a large chunk of spirit stones stuck in the wall."

"Do you have any questions?"

Wang Xiuying then asked, "Does mining a larger chunk of spirit stone increase its effectiveness? Why do I only see spirit stones the size of a pebble?"

"Great question. There's actually a reason why they're so small and not bigger, and it's simply because having a bigger size doesn't mean it'll have more spiritual energy. A fist-sized spirit stone and a pebble-sized spirit stone will have the same amount of spiritual energy; it's just how the heavens made it work."

"However, that doesn't mean you can make the spirit stones extremely small, as spirit stones will lose effectiveness if they become too small. After millions of years of practice and experience, the cultivators have figured out the perfect size for spirit stones, and that has become the standard."

"I see..."

Sometime later, they left the Spirit Stone Cave.

"What should we do now?" Yuan asked her.

"There's nothing to do besides looking around the city." Xi Meili said.

"Then what do you normally do?" Wang Xiuying asked her.

"I train— all day. I rarely go outside," she said, surprising them, as she looked like the type that really enjoyed going outside.

"In fact, I haven't explored the city like I have with you guys for many years. If I ever go outside, it would be to fight the others at the Ancestral Dragon Temple. It sounds boring, right? But I really love training and improving myself." Xi Meili said with a smile on her face.

"I see, since this is such a rare chance, let's go look around the city some more," Yuan said to her.

"Okay!" Xi Meili nodded with excitement.

Thus, they made their way towards the city and began another round of exploration whilst trying new food whenever they would encounter them.

Time passed extremely quickly, and in what felt like the blink of an eye, it was already dark.

Yuan logged off the game after eating dinner with the Royal Family.

The moment Yuan logged off the game and returned to his room, a strong and rich aroma assaulted his nose, making his mouth immediately salivate.

'Wow! What an amazing smell! What could Meixiu be cooking?' Yuan wondered inwardly, his imaginations running wild.

Sometime later, Meixiu entered his room and helped him sit up on the bed.

"What's for dinner?" Yuan quickly asked her.

"Beef stew," she responded in a calm voice.

And she continued, "Although it's still somewhat like soup, there are large meat chunks in there, and it comes with rice."

"As long as I can chew on it, I won't complain!" Yuan said.

"Give me a moment..." Meixiu then placed a blanket in front of him just in case any food was to fall, and she proceeded to feed him beef stew.

"This food is amazing! The meat is tender, like that Dragon Meat Skewer I had not long ago! I didn't know you were such a good cook! Of course, your soup tastes good too, but this is a different level!" Yuan praised her after a single bite.

"Thank you..." Meixiu said with a slight smile on her face, as she couldn't help but feel happy after hearing his praises, especially when she'd worked her butt off during training to reach this level.

After dinner, Meixiu asked him, "How do you feel?"

"Well... To be completely honest, I am not full. However, the food was great." Yuan said.

"Not full, huh... Well, this is what Doctor Wang advised, but I will let him know that you're not full. By the way, for reference, how much do you think you can still eat?"

"I can probably eat two to three more meals of this size no problem," he said.

"T-That much?" Meixiu looked at him with wide eyes. Fortunately, they have plenty of money from selling the treasure, or it would be a struggle feeding him.

"Okay."

After dinner, Meixiu relayed the news to Doctor Wang.

Of course, Doctor Wang wasn't surprised that the meal wasn't enough for Yuan, as he'd purposefully made it so that Yuan wouldn't be full so that his stomach would adapt to the new diet.

"Continue feeding him this amount for the next three days, then you can slowly increase the amount." Doctor Wang instructed her over the phone.

"I understand. Thank you." Meixiu said to him.

The following morning, Yuan and Wang Xiuying followed Xi Meili around the city again.

And in the blink of an eye, another day passed.

The three of them continued this until an entire week had passed.

"The teleport formation should be ready in three days." The Dragon Emperor said to them.

"Three days, huh? What do you guys want to do? Continue looking around the city? But we've looked at pretty much everything. If only you guys had more time here, we could've gone further." Xi Meili asked them.

"This may sound weird, but I'd like to practice my Dragon's Gaze with you." Yuan suddenly said, dumbfounding her.

Chapter 372 - Training With Xi Meili

"Y-You want to practice Dragon's Gaze? With me? But it's dangerous doing it outside the Ancestral Dragon Temple." Xi Meili said to him, worried that she might permanently injure him.

Yuan said, "That's right. You're more experienced with the technique, so I'd figured you can give me some advice. Furthermore, during our match, it felt like I was understanding more about the technique just from looking at your eyes. As for injuring me... you don't have to worry about it. I'll be fine."

"Well... I don't mind." Xi Meili said.

Yuan then turned to look at Wang Xiuying and said, "What about you?"

"Don't mind me. I will be watching you in the background," she said.

Sometime later, they arrived at the courtyard.

"I don't really know what kind of advice I should give you, so let's just use Dragon's Gaze on each other like we did during our match and see if you can understand anything from it." Xi Meili said to him.

Yuan nodded.

"Let's start slow." Xi Meili then stood about 10 meters away from him.

"We're going to slowly approach each other like previously. Ready when you are."

"I am ready," Yuan said.

"Then we'll use our Dragon's Gaze on the count of three... two... one... go!"

Whoosh!

A profound pressure immediately enveloped the courtyard when Yuan and Xi Meili's Dragon's Gaze collided, giving Wang Xiuying a nostalgic feeling. However, this time, she made sure to stand all the way back where the pressure didn't affect her as much.

A few moments later, once they were feeling a little comfortable, Yuan and Xi Meili began approaching each other.

And with each step they took, they increased the strength of their Dragon's Gaze.

Before they knew it, both of them were standing directly in front of each other again, silently staring right into each others' eyes like they wanted to see their soul.

Since this wasn't a match, Xi Meili didn't try to overwhelm Yuan, and she merely matched his strength, perhaps even slightly above him.

A few minutes later, Xi Meili asked him, "Well? Are you improving?"

"Can you increase the strength of your Dragon's Gaze some more? You don't have to go easy on me." Yuan said to her.

After a moment of silence, Xi Meili suddenly increased the strength of her Dragon's Gaze.

Although it wasn't quite as powerful as it was during the match, it was pretty close, and it was just enough to not injure him and enough to make him feel pressured.

Yuan quickly began sweating under Xi Meili's powerful Dragon's Gaze, feeling as though there was an almighty being staring down at him as though he was an ant.

A few minutes of pure silence later, once Xi Meili noticed Yuan reaching his limit, she closed her eyes and said, "Okay, let's take a rest here. Any more and you might suffer internal injuries, which is devastating for any cultivator."

"Okay." Yuan nodded, and he proceeded to sit down in the lotus position and closed his eyes, recalling everything he'd experienced just now.

An hour later, once they had recovered, Yuan and Xi Meili returned to their training, and they would continue this until the day ended.

The following day, they also continued to do the same thing.

On the third day, Yuan took a seat in the middle of the courtyard and closed his eyes to recall everything he's learned for the past two days.

Meanwhile, Wang Xiuying and the Royal Family watched him in the background.

"What do you think? After two days of training, how is his progress?" The Dragon Emperor asked Xi Meili.

"To be completely honest, he's terrifying— his talents. He absorbs all experience like a sponge absorbing water and greatly improves in a short time. I was able to see a clear difference and improvement in his Dragon's Gaze after every practice session." Xi Meili gave her judgment.

"If he continues to practice the technique, he'll most likely surpass me very soon."

"If only he wasn't born a human but a dragon instead. What a pity." Xi Murong sighed in a truly regretful tone.

"There's nothing wrong with being talented as a human, as talents don't favor a certain race. In the outside world, there are plenty of humans with talents that surpass even your father and me." The Dragon Empress spoke with a solemn expression on her face.

Sometime later, a profound aura surrounded Yuan.

When the Royal Family saw this, their eyes widened with shock.

"Enlightenment! He's experiencing enlightenment!" Xi Murong exclaimed in a baffled voice.

"Shut your mouth! Don't you dare disturb him!" The Dragon Empress immediately slapped the back of his head while lecturing him.

"What's an enlightenment?" Wang Xiuying asked in a whispering voice.

"Enlightenment is a trance-like state where your mind and heart becomes crystal clear to focus on one thing— whatever caused the enlightenment." Xi Meili explained.

And she continued, "When that happens, one will improve drastically at whatever they are trying to gain enlightenment on."

"For example, Yuan's probably having enlightenment about the Dragon's Gaze. Once he's done, his understanding and mastery of the technique will improve drastically."

"I see... How long do enlightenments usually last?"

The Dragon Emperor said, "It depends on the complexity of whatever he's having enlightenment about. If it's a simple technique, he can be done in a matter of minutes."

"However, if he's having an enlightenment about something complex— like Dragon's Gaze, he could be in that state for days if not weeks."

"W-Weeks?!" Wang Xiuying exclaimed in a low voice. What will happen to the Mystic Realm? And it's not like she could take him out of enlightenment!

"Don't worry, we have already prepared the teleport formation, so you can leave whenever. It doesn't have to be today. If you want, you can even return by yourself first. He can follow you after he's done." The Dragon Emperor said to her.

However, Wang Xiuying shook her head and said, "No, it's okay. I will stay here until the very last minute. We came here together, so we'll leave together— at least we'll try."

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Chapter 373 - The Real Player

Yuan

"I will stay here to watch over him. You guys can leave." Xi Meili volunteered to stay behind even though that wasn't necessary. However, she wanted to be here when he woke up so that she could congratulate him.

"Are you sure? This will take some time. We can simply block access to this area so that nobody could disturb him." The Dragon Emperor said to her.

"Yes, I want to stay here." Xi Meili nodded.

"Do as you please..."

The Dragon Emperor left with the others shortly after.

"What happened to her? It's like she's obsessed with him." The Dragon Empress asked her husband after they left, as she was unaware of the bet he made with Yuan.

"She likes him." The Dragon Emperor said with a slight smile on his face, and he continued, "And she wants to marry him."

"What?"

Everybody there turned to look at him with wide eyes filled with shock, especially Wang Xiuying and Xi Murong.

"She wants to marry that human?! A dragon with royal lineage?! That's blasphemy towards our bloodline!" Xi Murong exclaimed, clearly disapproving of her decision.

Meanwhile, Wang Xiuying wondered what would happen if a player marries an NPC.

'There are plenty of players out there that are currently in a romantic relationship with an NPC, so I guess marriage isn't too far-fetched...' She thought to herself.

"I think it's cute." The Dragon Empress said, and she continued, "I couldn't care less if she wants to marry a human or a dragon. I only care about one thing—his qualifications. And from my understanding, Yuan is more than qualified to join our Royal Family."

"Y-You too, mother?" Xi Murong looked at her with disbelief.

"Anyways, it's her decision, and I will respect it." The Dragon Empress said.

Then she looked at Xi Murong and said, "If you have a problem with it, why don't you confront her about it?"

"I... I would rather not..." Xi Murong responded in a reserved voice.

Despite being the older one, he feared Xi Meili a little, especially whenever she's angry.

Sometime later, the Royal Family returned to their business whilst Wang Xiuying returned to her room before logging off.

"Since it's going to take some time before he wakes up, I'll take a small break from the game and help grandpa out at the hospital." Wang Xiuying mumbled to herself after leaving the game.

After stretching her body, Wang Xiuying left her room and went downstairs to watch some television.

In this day and age that's dominated by video games, it was only natural for television to be heavily involved with video games. In fact, the most popular channels in the world are gaming channels that talk about the current trends and whatnot for certain video games.

"Let's see if there are any new trends for Cultivation Online..." Wang Xiuying went to the channel that was dedicated to Cultivation Online news.

"Today, we will be interviewing one of the players in Cultivation Online who claims to be Player Yuan!" The speaker on the television spoke while a young man wearing a black mask sat beside him.

Wang Xiuying immediately raised her eyebrows after seeing this 'Player Yuan' who was obviously a fake.

"Another one? How many people have come forward as the real Player Yuan now? I have already lost count. These people clearly know he's a fake, yet they are still giving him a spotlight. What are these people thinking?" Wang Xiuying shook her head.

Because of Player Yuan's fame and the fact that nobody knows his real identity, it was only natural for people to try and claim they were Player Yuan and steal his fame, but alas, not a single person has managed to prove themselves to be the real one despite dozens of people coming forward as the real one.

"Tell me— and the audience watching this— why should we believe you when you claim to be Player Yuan? What kind of proof can you provide us that proves you're the real one? And if you are indeed the real one, why have you suddenly decided to reveal yourself after remaining lowkey for so long?"

The man with the black mask then spoke in a confident voice, "I simply got bored of hiding, so I decided to come out of hiding. As for whether I have proof or not— of course, I have proof. Why else would I come all the way over here?"

The presenter then said with a stiff smile on his face, "You sound so confident that I am already starting to believe you."

And he continued, "Let's start with the easy questions first."

"Why did you decide to play Cultivation Online?"

"Because I was bored."

"What cultivation are you currently in Cultivation Online?"

"First level Spirit Master."

"How old are you?"

"Eighteen years old."

"What are you currently doing in the event known as Mystic Realm?"

"Nothing too crazy. I'm just farming some magical beasts for points."

"Why have you refused to come out despite so many offers to reveal your identity?"

"I was skeptical of them, and I still am."

Wang Xiuying shook her head again.

"This is all common knowledge by now. What a waste of time."

Ever since Yuan's age and cultivation level was revealed right before they entered the Mystic Realm, it was spread throughout the internet like wildfire.

Many people couldn't believe how far ahead he actually was compared to the top players, much less the average players, and even more people were shocked by his young age.

After asking 'Player Yuan' a dozen useless questions that didn't directly prove that he was the real Player Yuan, the presenter then said, "This is all for today. Follow us on the next episode tomorrow for more proof! Find out whether he's really Player Yuan or just another phony tomorrow here, Cultivation Online Daily News!"

"What an idiot." Wang Xiuying closed the television afterward, no longer feeling any will to continue watching.

"Guess I'll go to the hospital now and see if grandpa needs any help there."

Thus, she took a few minutes to prepare herself before leaving the house.

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Chapter 374 - Not Logging Off

After arriving at her family's hospital that was owned by Doctor Wang, Wang Xiuying went to look for her grandfather.

"Grandfather, do you need any help around here?" She asked him.

"Hm? What happened to your game? I thought you were going to take the entire month off due to some massive event." Doctor Wang looked at her funny, especially when she was so excited not too long ago.

"Well, something happened, and I have some free time, so I figured that I'd come here and help out in the meantime," she said.

"I see... But I don't really need any help today. You can try asking the other nurses."

"Hmmm..."

After a moment of silence, Wang Xiuying spoke, "Grandpa, you visited Yu Tian recently, right? How's he doing? Considering how his family kicked him out... I'm kind of worried."

"The Young Master? He's doing perfectly fine." Doctor Wang said.

"Perfectly fine?" Wang Xiuying raised her eyebrows.

"Yes. I even decided to change his diet, so he's no longer just eating soup for every meal."

"Oh, that's great!"

"By the way... Do you think I can go visit him at his new place?" She suddenly asked.

"Eh? Why?"

"It's been a while, that's all. And I feel like speaking to him."

Doctor Wang pondered for a moment before speaking, "I will have to ask them for permission before I say anything."

"That's fine."

Doctor Wang called Meixiu shortly after, but nobody picked up, so he left her a message about Wang Xiuying wanting to visit.

Meanwhile, Wang Xiuying went to help out the others in the hospital.

It wasn't until after Meixiu logged off the game to prepare dinner that she saw Doctor Wang's message.

"Wang Xiuying wants to visit us?" Meixiu raised her eyebrows.

[I will ask him when he comes out of the game.]

She texted back to him.

[Okay. Thank you.] Doctor Wang responded a minute later.

However, Yuan didn't log off that night, missing his dinner.

"He must be busy inside the game."

Once Meixiu realized that Yuan was most likely going to stay inside the game for the night and miss dinner, she wrapped his food and placed them inside the fridge.

Meixiu wasn't too worried initially since this wasn't his first time forgetting to log off.

However, when Yuan didn't log off for the second and a third day, she grew increasingly worried that something might have happened to him.

She wanted to forcefully take him out of the game to ask him what was happening and why he hadn't logged off for so many days, but she'd resisted her urges, as she was worried that he might be doing something incredibly important in the game that wouldn't let him log off for whatever reason.

Furthermore, she has been checking his pulses just to make sure he was still alive and well.

"Haaa... If only I could see what he's doing..."

Meixiu sat on the floor beside the bed and rested her head on it.

'I haven't cooked or done anything in two days... It's a new record...' Meixiu thought to herself.

It was at this moment her phone rang.

She looked at the caller; it was Doctor Wang.

"Are you okay? It's been two days since you texted me. Did you forget or something?" Doctor Wang asked her through the phone.

"Sorry, it's not that... Yu Tian, he hasn't logged off the game yet." She revealed.

"What? How is that possible? It's been two whole days! That can't be healthy." Doctor Wang said.

"I would go over there now to check his condition, but I have an important meeting in a few minutes, so if you don't mind, I will send my granddaughter over to check his condition. Don't worry, you can trust her skills." Doctor Wang said.

"Okay." Meixiu quickly agreed.

She knew that Yuan and Wang Xiuying were on good terms, so he most likely wouldn't mind her visiting, especially if it's for a valid reason. Furthermore, Yuan told her that he was with Wang Xiuying inside the game, so maybe she knows something about his situation.

"I'll send her the address right now."

The connection closed shortly after, and Doctor Wang immediately contacted Wang Xiuying and told her about the situation.

"Yu Tian hasn't logged off for two whole days and Meixiu is worried? Okay, I will immediately go there now. What's the address?" Wang Xiuying spoke with a serious look on her face.

Although she was initially happy that Doctor Wang told her to visit Yu Tian, her excitement quickly subsided after hearing about the situation.

After receiving the address, Wang Xiuying grabbed her tools and made her way to Yuan's apartment.

"This is where he lives now?" Wang Xiuying raised her eyebrow at the apartment before her.

Sometime later, she entered the elevator and went to the 17th floor.

Wang Xiuying stood before 17F a moment later, and she knocked on the door.

"Hello! It's me, Wang Xiuying!"

Meixiu opened the door a few moments later to let her inside.

"I'll save the greetings for another time, Meixiu. Where's Yu Tian?" Wang Xiuying asked her.

"Here..."

Meixiu led her into Yuan's room.

Wang Xiuying didn't say anything and immediately checked his pulse.

"His pulses seem perfectly fine..." Wang Xiuying released a sigh of relief after confirming that he wasn't in danger.

"So did he tell you what he was doing the last time you spoke to him? Do you know why he hasn't logged off? Sometimes I also lose track of the time and stay inside the game for longer than I would like. However, two whole days is a little too much, especially since he knows that you'll be cooking food for him." Wang Xiuying said.

"I was hoping you could answer that question..." Meixiu said to her.

"Hm? What do you mean?" Wang Xiuying tilted her head.

Meixiu took a deep breath and said, "He told me that the two of you were playing together, so I was hoping you know why he's not coming out..."

In her mind, Yuan's well-being was more important than his identity in a video game, so if she had to reveal his identity to make sure he was okay, she would do it without any hesitation.

Furthermore, Wang Xiuying is Doctor Wang's granddaughter and Yuan's number one fan, so Meixiu felt that she could trust her with Yuan's identity.

Chapter 375 - Before Sunrise

"Huh? What do you mean I'm playing with Yu Tian?" Wang Xiuying's head remained tilted in a puzzled manner.

"The person I am playing with currently is—"

Wang Xiuying's eyes suddenly widened when she realized what Meixiu was trying to tell her.

She then slowly turned her head to look at Yu Tian, who was sleeping peacefully on the bed with the console on his head.

Although the console was blocking half of his head, she could still see some resemblance between Yu Tian and Yuan.

"A-Are you... Are you telling me that Yu Tian is Player Yuan?" Wang Xiuying asked her for confirmation, as she was in disbelief.

Meixiu nodded silently.

"So he knew this entire time who I was?" Wang Xiuying mumbled in a low voice.

To think she'd been playing with her number one idol, Yu Tian, this entire time without being aware! And she even saw his face! What a blunder on her part!

"Please keep this a secret between us, Wang Xiuying. We cannot risk his identity being leaked outside, hence why he didn't tell you." Meixiu said to her afterward.

"D-Don't worry, I won't tell a single soul. I promise!" Wang Xiuying quickly said after snapping out of her daze.

Meixiu nodded, "I trust you."

"Anyways, now that I know Yu Tian is Player Yuan, I understand why he's like this." Wang Xiuying said.

And she continued, "He's currently in a state of enlightenment, and I was told that he wouldn't wake up until he finishes."

"Enlightenment? How long will it take before he wakes up?" Meixiu asked.

Wang Xiuying sighed and said, "I was told it could take days... even weeks."

"Weeks?!" Meixiu exclaimed.

A few days were already unreasonably long, much less a couple of weeks. Can one even survive that long without eating?

"Don't worry, Meixiu. I know what you're thinking, but there have been plenty of people out there who have remained inside the game for over a week without any problems." Wang Xiuying said to her.

"Even if you say that, I cannot let him stay inside the game for so long. I don't want anything to happen to him." Meixiu said, as she couldn't help but worry about it.

Wang Xiuying nodded and said, "I think so as well, so let's give him one or two more days to leave by himself before we forcefully wake him up."

And she continued, "I will monitor him inside the game and you will monitor him here."

"Okay." Meixiu nodded.

Sometime later, after making sure that Yuan was completely fine and healthy, Wang Xiuying left the place and returned home.

"Player Yuan was Yu Tian all along? I still cannot believe it..." Wang Xiuying laid on her bed and stared at the empty ceiling with a dazed look on her face for a very long time.

Sometime later, she entered the game and went to the courtyard behind the Royal Palace, where Yuan was still sitting in the lotus position with his eyes closed. Sitting a few meters away from him was Xi Meili, who was staring at him with a profound expression, her thoughts unknown.

A few moments later, Wang Xiuying took a seat beside Xi Meili.

Xi Meili remained still, almost like she didn't notice Wang Xiuying sitting beside her.

'He's Yu Tian...' Wang Xiuying thought to herself as she gazed at Yuan's handsome face.

After a minute of silence, Xi Meili suddenly said, "I really like him."

"Huh?" Wang Xiuying turned to look at Xi Meili with a surprised look on her face.

Xi Meili acted like nothing was out of the ordinary and continued in a calm voice, "He's the only person that has managed to pique my interest so much. Even now, I cannot take my eyes off him."

"What about you? Do you like him as much as I do?" Xi Meili suddenly asked, dumbfounding her.

Wang Xiuying then turned to look at Yuan and spoke with a smile on her face, "I really admire him."

"Admiration?" Xi Meili finally turned to look at her, as she was surprised by Wang Xiuying's answer.

Wang Xiuying nodded and said, "He— at a very young age, was able to impress and influence many people with his talents, and I was one of these people that he'd influenced."

"His talent, huh? I kind of understand that feeling, as he has also influenced me just by showing off his talents." Xi Meili nodded.

"Hmm? Wait a second. I thought you didn't know him, since you said that you'd followed him on a whim." Xi Meili suddenly realized this.

An awkward smile appeared on Wang Xiuying's face, and she said, "Well, yeah... That's what I thought at first, but it appears that I have known him for quite some time now."

"Sorry, but I don't understand..." Xi Meili said.

"It's fine if you don't understand since I am also trying to wrap my own head around it."

The two of them returned to being silent shortly after, and they continued to stare at Yuan with a silent gaze and their own thoughts.

At the end of the day, right as Wang Xiuying prepared to log off the game, she noticed that the aura around Yuan was beginning to change.

"What's happening to him?" She couldn't help but ask.

"Unbelievable..."

However, Xi Meili didn't respond and only mumbled with a look of disbelief on her face.

"D-Did something happen?" Wang Xiuying became worried.

"No... It's just that... He's already reaching the end of his enlightenment. At this rate, he'll finish before sunrise." Xi Meili said in a nervous voice.

"It's only been three days since he started his enlightenment for the Dragon's Gaze, a deeply profound and complex technique for dragons, and he's already reaching the end. I can only describe his comprehension talents as god-like..."

"For comparison, when I had an enlightenment of the technique, it took me three months to finish my enlightenment."

"T-Three months?!" Wang Xiuying looked at her with wide eyes, as she cannot imagine anyone sitting there without moving for so long.

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Chapter 376 - Mastery Level 3

"I-I will be right back!" Wang Xiuying said to Xi Meili before logging off the game and picking up her phone.

"Hello?" Meixiu quickly answered the phone after seeing Wang Xiuying's name as the caller.

"Hey, Meixiu, great news. I think Yuan will be done by sunrise," she relayed this news to her.

"Really?" Meixiu asked.

"Yes, and I will stay inside the game tonight to let him know about the situation."

"Thank you very much, Wang Xiuying," Meixiu said to her.

"Don't worry about it. I am only doing what's natural. Then I'll speak with you again later."

After hanging up, Wang Xiuying went back into the game and waited for Yuan to finish his enlightenment with Xi Meili by her side.

Meanwhile, inside Yuan's mind, he could only see a pair of golden eyes staring at him from a distance that grew closer the longer he stared at it.

This pair of eyes resembled Xi Meili's eyes, but it also gave him a feeling of the Great One.

Although Yuan was not aware of it himself, he has been staring at this pair of eyes for the last three days inside his mind.

Suddenly, a familiar sound echoed in his mind.

Ding!

[Your comprehension for Dragon's Gaze has improved tremendously from enlightenment]

[Your comprehension for Dragon's Gaze has reached a new level]

[Dragon's Gaze Mastery Level (2) → (3)]

[Dragon's Gaze]

[Rank: Ancient]

[Mastery Level: 3]

[Description: A technique created by the 'Great One'. A single gaze will cause Immortals to bow and the Heavens to tremble in fear! Used by Royal Families of the Dragon Race.]

After the notification resounded, the pair of golden eyes inside Yuan's mind slowly closed itself before disappearing.

Yuan slowly opened his eyes afterward.

"Congratulations on your enlightenment, Yuan." Xi Meili greeted him with a bright smile on her pretty face.

"Xi Meili? Did I just experience another enlightenment?" He mumbled in a dazed voice.

"Another enlightenment? Why am I not surprised that this isn't your first time?" Xi Meili said with a bittersweet smile on her face.

"How long has it been in that state?" Yuan asked.

However, before Xi Meili could answer that question, Wang Xiuying stood up and approached him with a serious-looking expression on her face.

"Wang Xiuying? What's the matter?" Yuan asked her in a somewhat nervous voice because of the way she approached him.

"Yuan... or should I call you Yu Tian?" Wang Xiuying said to him.

"W-W-What did you just call me?" Yuan's eyes widened with shock when he heard his real name come out of Wang Xiuying's mouth— or at least that's what he thought he heard.

"I know the truth, Yu Tian. To think you were Player Yuan all along. I feel foolish for not recognizing you earlier..." Wang Xiuying sighed.

"H-How...? How did you find out?" Yuan asked her.

Did she finally recognize him from his appearance? But even if he looked similar to his appearance in the real world, she didn't have solid proof that they were the same person! And judging by the way Wang Xiuying is speaking, it sounded like she was absolutely confident about his identity!

"As much as I hate to admit it, I didn't find out by myself. It was Meixiu who told me." Wang Xiuying said.

"What? Meixiu told you my identity? Impossible!" Yuan became even more shocked after hearing this, feeling a little betrayed that Meixiu would reveal his identity to someone— even if that person was someone he trusted! And this made him feel extremely uncomfortable for some reason.

"Do you have any idea how worried Meixiu was because of you?" Wang Xiuying then said.

"What?"

Seeing Yuan's puzzled face, Wang Xiuying decided to reveal everything to him.

"You have been in enlightenment for three whole days, Yuan. That means you haven't logged off for three days!"

"WHAT?!"

When Yuan realized the situation, his heart immediately sank.

He'd been inside the game for three days straight?! No wonder why Meixiu would be worried!

"And because she had no idea what you were doing, she told me the truth about your identity. I was also very worried at first when I learned that you haven't logged off for three days. I even visited your apartment to check your condition!"

"Heavens! I will be right back! I need to speak with Meixiu as soon as possible!" Yuan said to her, and without waiting for a response, he immediately logged off the game.

"Uhhh..." Xi Meili was left speechless by their confusing conversation just now, but when Yuan disappeared, her questions also disappeared, almost like she suddenly forgot about them.

"Meixiu!" Yuan called for her the moment he returned to the real world.

"Yuan! You're finally back!" Meixiu released a deep sigh of relief after hearing his voice again.

"I am so sorry! It was never my intention to stay inside the game for so long! I had another sudden enlightenment, which completely screwed with my sense of time." Yuan explained to her why he didn't log off for so long.

"It's okay, you don't have to say anything. I have already heard of your situation from Wang Xiuying. I am just relieved that you're okay." Meixiu said to him.

"Even if you say that... I am really sorry for making you worried!"

"I would be lying if I told you that I wasn't worried, but thanks to Wang Xiuying for telling me the situation, it wasn't too bad."

Sometime later, once they calmed down, Meixiu said, "Now it's my turn to apologize. I promised to keep your identity a secret, yet I revealed your identity to Wang Xiuying... I am sorry..."

"What are you talking about? You had a legitimate reason to do so. Although I felt a little betrayed at first, I didn't know anything at that time. Just know that I don't blame you at all, Meixiu." Yuan said to her.

"Okay..." Meixiu said.

A few moments later, Meixiu asked him, "How is your body feeling right now? Do you feel hungry? It's been three days since you last ate, after all."

"Now that you mention it, I do feel a little hungry."

"I will go cook something right away," Meixiu said before going outside to prepare for his breakfast.

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Chapter 377 - Golden Dragon Robe

After cooking more breakfast than she's supposed to because Yuan hasn't eaten anything in three days, Meixiu slowly fed Yuan.

Sometime later, after breakfast, Yuan said to Meixiu, "I should be returning to the Mystic Realm today."

Then, he returned to the game whilst Meixiu cleaned the dishes.

"Welcome back." Wang Xiuying said to him.

"I'm really sorry for the trouble I have caused you two, Wang Xiuying," Yuan said.

"Don't worry about it anymore. We're already long past that. Anyways, the teleport formation is ready, and we can return to the Mystic Realm whenever we want."

Yuan nodded and said, "Give me a few more minutes here."

He then turned to look at Xi Meili and said to her, "Thank you for your hospitality and for training me."

Xi Meili smiled and said, "You can thank me by coming back here in the future so that we can play together again. There's still a lot of places I want to show you in this world."

"I would love to return to this place again, but since I came here by accident..."

"I believe that you'll return to this place again. If you came here once... you'll definitely come here a second time." Xi Meili said to him.

Yuan nodded.

"Let's go see my father so that he can activate the teleport formation for you."

Yuan and Wang Xiuying proceeded to follow Xi Meili to see her father, the Dragon Emperor.

"What? You're already finished with your enlightenment?"

As expected, the Dragon Emperor was greatly surprised to see Yuan awake so quickly.

After his initial surprise, the Dragon Emperor brought Yuan and Wang Xiuying to the teleport formation—the same one they came to this world from.

"It was very nice meeting the two of you. It's like a breath of fresh air in our monotonous life." The Dragon Emperor said, and he continued, "If you ever have the chance, you should come back."

"I will try." Yuan nodded.

"Good. Then stand on the teleport formation." The Dragon Emperor instructed them.

Yuan and Wang Xiuying followed his instructions and stepped onto the formation.

"Wait a second!" Xi Meili suddenly said.

"Before you leave, accept this small gift from me." She then handed Yuan a storage pouch.

"Don't open it now," she said afterward.

"Thank you," Yuan said after accepting the storage pouch.

"You too, Wang Xiuying." Xi Meili handed her a storage pouch as well.

"T-Thank you!" Wang Xiuying gladly accepted the gift, silently wondering what was inside.

"I'll activate the teleport formation now." The Dragon Emperor then said.

"Goodbye, everyone!" Yuan said to the Royal Family.

"Bye-bye!"

"Good luck out there, you two." The Dragon Empress said to them.

"See you next time!" Xi Meili said.

The Dragon Emperor then dropped a single drop of his blood onto the teleport formation, causing it to shine brightly.

A few seconds later, a familiar feeling enveloped Yuan and Wang Xiuying as they disappeared from the teleport formation and left the Ancient Dragon City.

Then, a beautiful pillar of light appeared, piercing the heavens.

Meanwhile, in Spirit Heaven, the same pillar of light appeared from the heavens and shot downwards into the ground, acting the complete opposite compared to its previous appearance.

This pillar of light then appeared in the Lower Heavens, aimed directly at the Mystic Realm.

The spectators outside the Mystic Realm were shocked when the pillar of light returned.

"What the heck is happening this time?!" Someone there exclaimed his frustration.

The pillar of light lingered for a minute before disappearing.

Inside the Mystic Realm, Yuan and Wang Xiuying returned to the 10th floor of the Mystic Pagoda.

"We're really back..." Wang Xiuying released a sigh of relief after realizing that they'd finally returned to the Mystic Realm.

"Looks like it." Yuan nodded.

"Let's quickly get off this floor just in case it activates again." Wang Xiuying said to him.

Yuan nodded, and they both went downstairs to the ninth floor.

On the ninth floor, Wang Xiuying took a seat on the stiff bed and opened her storage pouch to see what was inside, as her curiosity had long reached its peak.

"Wow! There are so many spirit stones inside!" Wang Xiuying exclaimed in a surprised voice.

"Really?"

Yuan looked at her with his interest piqued as well.

"There are at least 1,000 spirit stones in here! If I recall correctly, each spirit stone is worth 10,000 gold! That's 10 million gold worth of spirit stones in here!" Wang Xiuying was shocked by her sudden wealth.

"What about you, Yuan?" Wang Xiuying asked him.

"Let me see..."

Yuan took a look inside the storage pouch.

"You're right. I also have around 1,000 spirit stones, and there's also something else in here..."

Yuan then retrieved a pair of black and gold robes with a dragon design on it from the storage pouch.

"Wow, what a cool-looking pair of robes. It kind of resembles the clothes the Dragon Emperor was wearing." Wang Xiuying said.

[Golden Dragon Robe]

[Grade: Divine]

[Quality: Peak]

[Mental Strength Required: 50,000]

[Soul Strength Required: 50,000]

[Description: An excellent piece of traditional clothing worn by Dragons of the Royal Family. Increased Charm by 100 and Luck by 50 when worn. Enchanted with 'Superior Physical Resistance' and 'Superior Mental Resistance'. Grants passive skill 'Dragon Aura' when worn.]

"This clothing is a Divine-grade treasure...?" Yuan mumbled in a dazed voice as he stared at the Golden Dragon Robe.

"Yuan, there's a note sticking to it." Wang Xiuying pointed to the piece of paper poking out of the Golden Dragon Robe's pocket.

Yuan picked it up and read it.

[Your clothes looked a little bit small for your size, so I went ahead and picked a new pair of clothes for you. I think it'll suit you well. See you next time. Xi Meili.]

"What a thoughtful person." Wang Xiuying smiled.

Yuan chuckled and said, "I will definitely have to return to the Ancient Dragon City in the future to return the favor now."

Chapter 378 - Exiting The Mystic Pagoda

"It's going to be hard to repay this favor though since it's a Divine-grade treasure..." Yuan mumbled.

"Wait... It's a Divine-grade treasure? This clothing?" Wang Xiuying's eyes widened with shock after hearing this.

"Yes." Yuan nodded.

Wang Xiuying was speechless. This Dragon Princess truly loved him deeply if she was willing to give him a Divine-grade treasure!

"I'm going to change now." Yuan then said.

"O-Okay..." Wang Xiuying turned around to give him some privacy.

A few moments later, Yuan said, "I am finished."

Wang Xiuying turned back around after hearing his words, and Yuan's new appearance stunned her for a good moment, as he looked incredibly handsome and charming in these new clothes, almost like he was royalty.

If she didn't know any better, she would've definitely mistaken him for royalty just by his appearance alone, not to mention this unfathomable aura around him.

"Yuan, you kind of give me the same feeling as the people in the Ancient Dragon City— like you've turned into a dragon." Wang Xiuying said.

"That's probably because of the 'Dragon Aura' from this robe."

"Dragon Aura? So it makes your presence like that of a dragon?"

"Something like that."

"What a convenient skill. Do you think she gave you this robe so that you can use your Dragon's Gaze safely? After all, as long as you wear that clothing, you'll be able to use your Dragon's Gaze without having to worry about the other Royal Families causing you trouble because you're a human."

"Oh! I didn't think of that! You're absolutely right, Wang Xiuying! As long as I am wearing this robe, I will be a 'dragon', allowing me to use my Dragon's Gaze more openly!" Yuan spoke with excitement.

"The Dragon Princess really thought it out, huh? I am admiring her more and more."

"Yes!" Yuan agreed.

"Are you ready to leave this place?" She asked him after putting on the clothes she'd lend him.

He nodded.

It was at this moment more notifications appeared before Yuan.

[Xi Meili has been added to your Bond!]

[Xi Meili's Bond level has increased to Acquaintance!]

[Xi Meili's Bond level has increased to Friend!]

[Royal Family Xi has been added to your Associations!]

[Because of your performance at 'Ancient Dragon City', your relationship with the Royal Family Xi has increased drastically!]

[Due to your actions at 'Ancient Dragon City', your Fame has increased by 50!]

'The Bond System? It's been a while since I last saw it. I wonder how it works...' Yuan thought to himself. The last time the Bond System activated was at Pang City.

"Yuan?" Wang Xiuying called out to him when he stood there with a dazed face.

"Sorry, I'm coming."

The two of them proceeded to go downstairs.

Before leaving the Mystic Pagoda, Yuan said, "Let me wear my mask first."

Wang Xiuying nodded and watched him put on his black mask that complimented his black robes perfectly.

"Okay, I am ready."

The two of them approached the door, which opened automatically.

Meanwhile, outside the Mystic Pagoda, most of the remaining participants had gathered there, and all of them had agreed to work with each other to figure out how they could open the Mystic Pagoda.

However, an entire week had passed without any progress, as the Mystic Pagoda remained sealed.

"What was that light just now? That was the second time I have seen it!" One of them asked when a pillar of light suddenly descended from the skies and landed on the Mystic Pagoda.

"I have no idea, but it's definitely related to this place. If we can figure it out, perhaps that'll be the key to opening this damn place!" Another one said.

"But we have already searched every nook and cranny in this area. What else can we do at this point?"

"Keep searching! There must be a way to open the door!"

While the participants tried everything to open the Mystic Pagoda, completely unbeknownst to these people, three figures had been watching their every action for the past week from the skies.

"Look at these outsiders dirtying our Lord's Mystic Pagoda with their filthy presence! If I could, I would kill every single one of them for disrespecting the sacred ground!" Grandpa Lan mumbled in a loathing voice.

"Calm down, old man. You'll shorten your lifespan if you get angry over these idiots." Grandma Lan shook her head.

Ever since Yuan's death, Grandpa Lan has been acting like a grumpy old man who's easily bothered by even the slightest things.

"What is that pillar of light, anyway? I have never seen anything like that before." Lan Yingying said a moment later.

"I don't know. It's also my first time witnessing such a phenomenon. I hope it's not a bad sign..." Grandpa Lan said.

It was at this moment one of the participants there suddenly shouted in a shocked voice, "L-Look! The door is opening!"

"What?!"

Everybody there immediately turned to look at the Mystic Pagoda, and sure enough, the door was opening.

"T-The Mystic Pagoda opened? How?"

Even the Lan Family in the sky was greatly bewildered by this random occurrence.

"I'm going down there! I cannot let these outsiders' dirty feet step into the Lord's home!" Grandpa Lan said.

And just as he prepared to descend from the sky, his movements halted when he noticed two figures walking out of the Mystic Pagoda.

The first person to come out was a pretty young lady at the Spirit Warrior realm. The second person was an individual wearing a black mask who was also emitting this unfathomable aura that made the people around him admire him unconditionally, almost like he was royalty.

"Who are those people?! And how did they come out of the Mystic Pagoda?!" Grandpa Lan was baffled by their mysterious presence, especially when he saw the person in the black mask and clothes, as the aura he gave off resembled that of a beast rather than a human.

"H-Hey! Who the heck are you two?! And how long have you been inside the Mystic Pagoda?!" The participants on the ground asked them.

"W-Wait! I recognize you! You're Healer Wang from Medicine Valley!" One of the participants who was also a player recognized Wang Xiuying's pretty face.

"Whoa... There are so many people here..." Wang Xiuying was also surprised to see them, as she didn't expect to be surrounded by people the moment she left the Mystic Pagoda.

"What?! Does this mean you're also a participant?! How did you enter the Mystic Pagoda?!" The participants immediately began questioning her.

"Ehh..." Wang Xiuying took a few steps until she was standing behind Yuan.

"Answer us! How did you enter the Mystic Pagoda, and how long have you two been inside?!" The participants slowly surrounded them, sealing even the smallest path so that they couldn't escape.

"Are all of you participants?" Yuan asked them in a low voice.

"That's right!" One of them answered.

"Good."

Yuan didn't say anything else and retrieved the Empyrean Overlord, his intentions clear.

"W-Wait! A mask! That sword! You're that monster from the Dragon Essence Temple!"

Some of the participants quickly connected the dots and realized his identity.

However, they were not the only ones who realized this.

"That sword! Impossible!" Grandpa Lan's eyes nearly popped out of their sockets when he saw the Empyrean Overlord in the masked man's grasp.

"Yuan?! He's still alive?!" Lan Yingying covered her mouth from shock, and tears immediately began flowing from her eyes when she realized that he'd survived the Demon Lord's Core Detonation!

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Chapter 379 - Beauty Falling From The Sky

"W-What do you think you're doing?" The participants there looked at Yuan with nervous expressions when they saw that he'd suddenly retrieved his weapon and was standing there menacingly.

"L-Let's talk this out first, okay? There's no need for pointless bloodshed... We're all in this together..."

However, Yuan completely ignored them, and he lifted his Empyrean Overlord into the air.

"R-Run! He's going to kill us all!" One of the participants there suddenly shouted.

"Fuck you, you damn coward! Look at how many of us there are and how many they have! As if there's any need to run! Don't forget! He's no longer a Spirit Master in this world! We can take him!" Another participant refuted, even suggesting that they fight him together.

"Y-Yeah! Let's get him! All of us together! There's no way he'd be able to defeat so many of us at once!"

The participants there all prepared for battle, yet none of them dared to approach him first.

Yuan closed his eyes and took a deep breath.

When he opened them, it flickered with a vicious light.

[Heavenly Domain!]

The place was suddenly assaulted by a tyrannical pressure that caused all of the participants there to feel as though they were carrying mountains on their back whilst their bodies were chained down, completely sealing their movements.

"W-What is this?! I can't move my body!"

One by one, the participants there began lowering their bodies until their knees were kissing the ground.

In just a few moments, everyone there was on their knees, almost as though they were greeting royalty— if not for the terrified expressions on their faces.

"W-Wait! Let's not be so hasty, alright? Let's talk—"

One of the participants there opened his mouth to speak, but before he could even finish his sentence, Yuan swung the Empyrean Overlord in his grasp in a wide motion.

Whoosh!

A massive red arc of sword light was released from the strike, sweeping through the participants there and slicing their bodies in half instantly.

"Ah!"

"Damn it!"

"I'll remember this!"

The participants cried out loud as their bodies disappeared from the Mystic Realm before appearing outside the gates.

After his initial swing, Yuan went to clean up the other participants he'd missed.

And in less than a minute, over 90 participants perished from the Mystic Realm and were disqualified from the event.

Meanwhile, outside the Mystic Realm, the spectators were shocked speechless by what they'd just witnessed.

"Is that the Young Master? He looks somewhat different..." Feng Yuxiang mumbled in a dazed voice as she stared at his figure in the mirror.

"Brother Yuan..." Xiao Hua released a sigh of relief after seeing that he was fine.

However, they were only able to see Yuan for a brief moment. Once Yuan killed all of the participants in the Mystic Realm, the mirror no longer spectated him anymore.

This baffled Senior Nie and the others.

"What the hell is going on with the Mystic Realm this year? How come the treasure isn't spectating that participant? And how did he open the Mystic Pagoda?" Senior Nie was filled with questions inside his head.

"Who was that masked figure just now?! Is he also a participant?! And did he just come out of the Mystic Pagoda?!"

The elders in Spirit Heavens were also greatly shocked by Yuan's presence, and they immediately bombarded Senior Nie with questions.

"He's a participant from the Dragon Essence Temple. Although his appearance is different from when he first entered, I cannot forget that Soul Weapon. However, I have no other information regarding his identity besides that."

"Oh yeah, he was also a Spirit Master before he entered the Mystic Realm, and he's apparently only 18 years old." Senior Nie added.

"What! Such a genius exists in the Lower Heavens?! We must secure him at all costs!" One of the elders said.

"I think so too... But which of our sect should he join?"

"He'll be joining my sect, of course!" Someone then said.

"Nonsense! Why should he join yours?!" Another one refuted.

"Because he's using a sword, and we're a sword sect! Why else?!"

"So what if he's using a sword? He can still join other sects! I have plenty of sword cultivators in my sect that focus on other weapons!" A second person refuted.

The experts began fighting over who would get to take Yuan in as their disciple.

Senior Nie shook his head and said, "You guys... You can discuss that after he agrees to follow us back to Spirit Heaven."

"What? Isn't that a no-brainer? Who would refuse to ascend?"

"Right? Who in their right mind would rather stay in this dump when they could ascend without any effort? If you're a true cultivator, you'd want to reach the peak!"

The elders didn't believe that anyone could possibly willingly refuse to ascend to the Spirit Heavens.

"I don't know... He seemed to be acquainted with that little girl who was a Spirit King... I wouldn't be surprised if they don't really belong to the Lower Heavens and only came down here for whatever reason like I did."

"Really? Just what are their backgrounds?"

"Only the Heavens know..." Senior Nie sighed.

"Hahaha! Do you see that? That's our Dragon Essence Temple's number one genius!" Long Yijun laughed out loud after seeing so many participants disqualified at once.

The other Sect Masters looked at him in envy. Why don't they also have a monster disciple in their sect?

Inside the Mystic Realm, after killing all of the participants, Yuan stows away the Empyrean Overlord.

"I didn't know you could be this ruthless, Yuan..." Wang Xiuying said with a smile.

"Well—"

"Yuan!"

Just as Yuan opened his mouth, he heard a familiar voice resound above him, causing him to look up into the sky.

And to his surprise, Lan Yingying was falling from the sky with her arms spread wide open and a blissful look on her face.

Yuan instinctively opened his arms to catch her.

A moment later, Lan Yingying landed in his arms and embraced him tightly, "Thank the Lord! You're still alive, Yuan!"

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Chapter 380 - Master Of The Mystic Realm

"Yuan! Is it really you?! Are you really not a ghost?!" Lan Yingying tightly embraced him to make sure that he was real.

"What is going on? Who is this?" Wang Xiuying was surprised when a beauty suddenly fell from the sky.

"M-Miss Lan? What are you doing here?" Yuan asked her in a dumbfounded voice after catching her from the sky.

"We came to the Mystic Pagoda to check up on the phenomenon that occurred here recently, but to think we'd see you here!" Lan Yingying said.

"We?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

A second later, two more figures descended from the sky.

"Grandpa Lan! Grandma Lan!" Yuan was pleasantly surprised to see them as well.

"Are you really the young man...? How on earth did you survive the Demon Lord's Core Detonation? And where have you been this whole time?" Grandpa Lan asked him with a dazed look on his face, almost like he was looking at a ghost.

Yuan then said, "It's a long story, but I barely managed to survive the blast. And thanks to my regeneration skill that I'd obtained from consuming the Demon Core, I was able to recover fully."

"Y-You obtained a skill from consuming the Demon Core...?" They all looked at him with baffled expressions.

"Anyways, it's relieving that you have managed to survive that blast." Grandpa Lan said.

"Yuan, who are these people?" Wang Xiuying asked him a moment later.

"They are the Lan Family, and they're natives in the Mystic Realm. They were also the first ones I met when I came to this place, and they have helped me a bunch since then." Yuan introduced the Lan Family to Wang Xiuying.

"H-Hello, I am Wang Xiuying, and I am a friend of Yuan..." Wang Xiuying greeted them.

"Any friend of Yuan is our friend." Grandpa Lan nodded, seemingly in great spirits.

"Anyways, how did you open the Mystic Pagoda, young man?" He turned to look at Yuan.

Yuan shrugged and said, "I honestly don't know. I think it has something to do with the Empyrean Overlord, but I don't have any solid proof. The door opens when I get close to it is all I know."

"I see... Interesting..." Grandpa Lan began pondering.

After a moment of silence, he spoke, "If you don't mind, can you show us the inside? I have always wondered what the Lord's living quarters looked like."

"W-Wait... Living quarters? This place?" Wang Xiuying said in a dazed voice.

"That's right. This place belongs to the Master of the Mystic Realm, who we call the 'Lord'." Grandpa Lan confirmed.

"Unbelievable... To think this mysterious place that cannot be opened by normal means turned out to be a living quarter for some individual... And here I thought it was a special place filled with treasures and whatnot." Wang Xiuying mumbled.

"It is a special place... but probably not in the sense that you outsiders are thinking." Grandpa Lan said with a smile on his face.

Sometime later, Yuan brought the Lan Family inside the Mystic Pagoda, leading them from the first floor all the way to the ninth floor.

During this whole time, Lan Yingying stayed close to Yuan like two peas in a pod. It was as though she was reluctant to leave his side after almost losing him once, and the grandparents found this cute of her.

Wang Xiuying, however, was puzzled by Lan Yingying's seemingly intimate relationship with Yuan, and she wondered what happened between them.

"This place is much more spacious than I'd expected... And by that, I mean there's nothing in here..." Grandpa Lan said after climbing all nine floors.

"There seems to be another floor to this place. I thought there were only nine floors?" Lan Yingying said after she noticed the 10th floor.

"Let's check it out." Grandpa Lan said.

"W-Wait! Don't go up there!" Yuan hastily said to them.

"Hm? Why not?" They looked at him with their eyebrows raised.

"Because there's a teleport formation up there that will take you to this place called Ancient Dragon City," Yuan said, and he proceeded to explain the Ancient Dragon City to the Lan Family.

"Is that so... No wonder why I can sense this inhuman aura around you..." Grandpa Lan said afterward. "So this is the feeling of a 'dragon'."

"I don't know how, but the Lord is most likely related to the Ancient Dragon City in some way for him to have a teleport formation to that place inside his home."

"Yuan, look at this... There's a slit here..." Lan Yingying suddenly pointed to the floor in front of the place where Yuan got his mask from.

"Oh, yeah. I noticed it before but didn't think too much about it." Yuan said.

"If you look closely at it, don't you think your Empyrean Overlord would fit perfectly inside this slit?" Lan Yingying said.

"What?" Yuan looked at her with wide eyes, then he turned to look at the somewhat unnaturally wide slit in the ground.

"Let me try it..."

Yuan then retrieved his sword and inserted it inside the slit.

And to his surprise, it was a perfect fit, almost like this slit was made for his sword.

The moment the tip of his sword reached the end of the slit, Yuan felt a 'click'.

Suddenly, the entire Mystic Pagoda began rumbling as though there was an earthquake.

"W-What's going on now?"

The shaking lasted for a good moment before it calmed down.

And when it did—

Ding!

[Congratulations! The Mystic Realm now recognizes you as its Master! You have become the Master of the Mystic Realm!]

[You have obtained the title 'Master of the Mystic Realm'!]

[You now have full command over the Mystic Realm!]

"Uhh... I think I just became the Master of the Mystic Realm," Yuan suddenly said, shocking everybody in the room.

"What?! How?!" Grandpa Lan exclaimed.

"Probably because of this?" Yuan pointed to the Empyrean Overlord that was inserted perfectly into the floor.

"Good lord... To think you can become the Master of the Mystic Realm in such a manner..." Grandpa Lan mumbled in a dazed voice, and then he realized that unless one had the Empyrean Overlord, it was literally impossible to become the master of the Mystic Realm!

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Chapter 381 - Forcefully Removed

"Now that I am the Master of the Mystic Realm, what can I do?" Yuan asked them.

"Literally anything you want." Grandpa Lan said.

"The Mystic Realm itself is a treasure, and as its master, you're like its god. If you desire, you can even change the landscapes in this world."

"Hmm..."

After pondering for a moment, Yuan spoke, "I think I want to open up the Mystic Realm, allowing the natives of this world to go outside."

"What? Really?" Grandpa Lan looked at him with wide eyes.

Yuan nodded and said, "You told me that the natives of this world dislike outsiders because of envy, right? That they're all stuck inside this world because of their ancestors' decision."

"If that's the case, I would like to free them."

As someone who loved to go on adventures and visit new places, Yuan pitied these Mystic Realm natives that are secluded inside this world like birds in a cage.

He then turned to look at Lan Yingying and said, "You also told me that you're interested in the outside world, right? If I open the Mystic Realm, you'll be able to go outside and experience it for yourself."

After a moment of silence. Grandpa Lan said, "If that's your decision, you may do as you please."

Yuan nodded, and he proceeded to ask, "How do I open up the Mystic Realm, though? And before I do that, can I forcefully remove people from the Mystic Realm? I would like to disqualify the other participants if I could in this manner."

Wang Xiuying couldn't help but chuckle after hearing his words.

"Yes, you can remove anyone you want. Just command the Mystic Realm to do so." Grandpa Lan said.

"How do I do that?"

"Just tell it to do so like you're speaking to someone."

"Really? Does it really work like that?" Yuan mumbled.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan said loudly, "Mystic Realm, can you kick out everyone who doesn't belong in this world? Ah, but don't kick out Wang Xiuying who's with me now."

Ding!

[Command acknowledged!]

[All outsiders shall be removed from the Mystic Realm]

A moment after Yuan's command, every single participant besides Wang Xiuying was suddenly teleported outside of the Mystic Realm, shocking everybody outside.

"What?! Why am I outside the Mystic Realm?! Has a month passed already?!" One of the participants exclaimed in a puzzled manner.

"Impossible! We should've had another two weeks inside!" Another one said.

"Then why are we all out here?! What's going to happen now?"

Senior Nie felt a headache incoming after seeing this phenomenon.

"Just what in heaven's name happened? Why did all of the participants suddenly get kicked out of the Mystic Realm?" One of the crystal balls spoke.

"Not everyone." Senior Nie said, and he continued, "There are two people missing... That genius from the Dragon Essence Temple and that girl from Medicine Valley."

Senior Nie remembered all of the participants before they went inside, so he knew who was still inside the Mystic Realm.

"What should we do now? This year's Mystic Realm is a complete bust."

"Hmmm..."

After a moment of silence, Senior Nie said, "Let's wait until everyone comes out of the Mystic Realm before I decide."

Meanwhile, amongst the participants that had been forcefully teleported out of the Mystic Realm, Gao Dongya and Xue Jiye looked around with disbelief on their faces, as they had been forcefully kicked out as well.

"What the fuck is happening?!" Gao Dongya cursed out loud, as they were extremely close to reaching the Mystic Pagoda.

In fact, they were able to see the Mystic Pagoda in the distance right before getting kicked out of the Mystic Realm!

"This is why I said we should hunt some magical beasts for points! Look at us now! Besides increasing our cultivation base, we don't have any other points! If our rank is screwed up because of that, the Sect Master will kill us!" Xue Jiye complained to him.

Gao Dongya would normally have a comeback for her complaints but he was speechless this time, as it was true that they didn't have many points.

"Where is Disciple Yuan? I don't see him out here." Xue Jiye suddenly realized that he wasn't with them.

"Perhaps he was disqualified before us." Gao Dongya said.

"Don't jinx it!" Xue Jiye quickly said.

Sometime later, Senior Nie said to them, "Everyone that just got kicked out of the Mystic Realm, you may return to your sect for now. I will announce the results once everyone is out."

"What? Does this mean there are still people inside the Mystic Realm? Why were we kicked out? Who decided that?" The disqualified participants were speechless.

Many minutes later, once the participants returned to their sects, Long Yijun stared at Gao Dongya and Xue Jiye with a deep frown on his face, yet he didn't look angry at all.

"I'm sorry, Sect Master. We have failed you." Gao Dongya said with his head lowered.

"I'm sorry, Sect Master." Xue Jiye also apologized.

After a moment of silence, Long Yijun spoke, "Don't worry about it too much. Although I am also upset about the results, this situation was completely unexpected and out of control. Hopefully, Disciple Yuan, who is still inside the Mystic Realm, won't disappoint us."

"What? Disciple Yuan is still inside?" Gao Dongya was surprised to hear this.

"Where was he this entire time? He was separated from us the moment we went inside." Xue Jiye said.

"I know. However, I don't know why he was separated from you two or where he went. All I know is that he's still safe and sound inside the Mystic Realm. In fact, he even managed to open the Mystic Pagoda." Long Yijun revealed to them.

"What?! He opened the Mystic Pagoda?! How?!" Gao Dongya exclaimed in a shocked voice, causing the other participants to look at him.

Who opened the Mystic Pagoda? The participants that were not there to witness Yuan coming outside the Mystic Pagoda were unaware of the situation. However, they would soon come to learn about everything from the others, greatly shocking them as well.

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Chapter 382 - Returning To The Cabin

Inside the Mystic Realm, after kicking out all of the participants, Yuan said in a calm manner, "Okay, I think I got rid of all of the participants. Do I now do the same for opening the Mystic Realm?"

Grandpa Lan nodded and said, "Yes, but I think you should let the natives know before you open it."

"How should I let them know? Gather all of them in one place?" Yuan asked.

"No, you don't need to do that much. Just speak to them using the Mystic Realm. You can broadcast your voice to everyone in this world if you wish. Just ask the Mystic Realm to help you."

Yuan nodded and said, "Mystic Realm, I would like to speak with everyone in this world, so make sure my voice can be heard by everyone."

[Command acknowledged]

[You may speak whenever]

"Ahem!" Yuan cleared his throat before his speech, and his voice echoed throughout the world for everyone to hear, almost as though there was a god speaking to them from above.

"Hello, everybody in the Mystic Realm. I will keep this brief. I have recently become the Master of the Mystic Realm, and as the new Master, I will be opening the Mystic Realm for those of you who wish to leave this world and go outside."

"There will be a portal near the Mystic Pagoda, so if you wish to leave, you may go through this portal, which will take you outside the Mystic Realm. That is all."

The natives were greatly shocked after hearing Yuan's words. There's a new Master for the Mystic Realm? And this person will be opening the Mystic Realm again? Why would this person do something like that for them? And who is the identity of this new Master?

The natives were also sketchy about this announcement. Nevertheless, many of these natives were desperate to leave the Mystic Realm, so a lot of people from around the Mystic Realm began preparing their trip to the Mystic Pagoda.

"Now that all of that is done, what else should I do?" Yuan asked.

"You have already done more than enough, young man." Grandpa Lan said with a smile on his face.

And he continued, "Everyone that has been yearning to leave this place will be finally able to do so. I can imagine the population in this world lowering by a lot in the next few weeks."

"How about I open the Mystic Realm for the people outside as well? This way, there will be more people coming into this world."

"Hm? You mean you're not going to take the Mystic Realm with you?" Grandpa Lan looked at him with wide eyes.

"Can I even take something this massive with me?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"Of course. You can take it with you like a Soul Weapon." Grandpa Lan nodded.

"But if I do that... How will people enter or leave this place?" Yuan asked.

"Well... They can't— at least not until you take out the treasure again."

After pondering for a moment, Yuan said, "I will leave the Mystic Realm where it has been for the last few hundred thousand years. This way, people can enter and leave as they wish, and the sects will be able to continue doing this event which decides the rank of their sects."

After all, even if he's the Master of the Mystic Realm, he has no real use for such a place, and it would be somewhat unfair to the people that have been relying on the Mystic Realm for so long if he took it with him.

"I understand. If that's your decision, then so be it." Grandpa Lan nodded.

"Yuan, what should we do now?" Wang Xiuying asked him a moment later.

"Since you have automatically disqualified all of the participants, there is no longer any reason for us to be here. We can simply leave whenever we want."

"You're right... I don't think we should linger in this place when everyone is already outside." Yuan agreed with her.

"There's no need to be in such a hurry, young man. How about we return to the cabin and have some tea before you leave? I also have something to give you." Grandpa Lan said to him.

"Okay." Yuan nodded.

"What about you? Do you want to come along? I can take you out of here if you wish."

"I don't want to leave alone. I can already imagine what might happen if I do..." Wang Xiuying shuddered at the thought of being surrounded by everyone outside the moment she leaves, asking her why she's the only one who didn't get kicked out.

"Great. Then let's go." Grandpa Lan said to them.

A moment later, they went outside, where Grandpa Lan transformed into his serpent form, shocking Wang Xiuying.

"Y-You're a magical beast?"

"A Divine Beast, to be exact." Grandpa Lan said with a smile.

"A Divine Beast...? Yuan, don't you also have a Divine Beast as a servant?" Wang Xiuying recalled one of his world announcements.

"What? You have a Divine Beast as a servant?" The Lan Family looked at him with their eyes wide with shock.

They didn't know Divine Beasts could be servants, as they are usually extremely prideful beings that would never lower themselves to become a servant.

"Yes, I do." Yuan nodded.

"Unbelievable..." Grandpa Lan mumbled.

Lan Yingying stared at Yuan silently, seemingly in deep thoughts.

"Get on my back. I'll carry you guys back to the Divine Forest." Grandpa Lan said to them.

"Let me create the exit for the natives first," Yuan said, and he commanded the Mystic Realm to create a portal right outside the Mystic Pagoda, which will let the natives finally leave this place.

Once that was done, he jumped on Grandpa Lan's back with Wang Xiuying and the others before flying into the sky and away from the Mystic Pagoda.

In the air, Wang Xiuying looked at Lan Yingying for a good moment before asking her, "If you don't mind me asking, what's your relationship with Yuan?"

"What...?" Lan Yingying pondered for a moment before speaking, "He impregnated me."

"He what?!" Wang Xiuying exclaimed, nearly falling off Grandpa Lan's back from shock after hearing Lan Yingying's shocking words.

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Chapter 383 - Farewell Gift

"Y-Yuan! Is that true?! You impregnated this young lady?!" Wang Xiuying turned to him for answers, as she couldn't believe that someone as innocent as Yuan would do something like that to a woman he'd only recently met.

Yuan nodded in a calm manner and confirmed, "Yes, she asked me to impregnate her, so I decided to help her."

"U-Unbelievable..." Wang Xiuying stared at him with clear disbelief on her face.

Finding out Yuan had impregnated another woman was akin to a hardcore fangirl finding out that her number one idol had a girlfriend for Wang Xiuying.

The shock she felt was unique and different from what Meixiu felt when she first found out about it.

After many moments of silence, Wang Xiuying spoke again, "W-Well... Congratulations! I cannot wait to see the baby in nine months!"

Wang Xiuying was unaware that Divine Beasts had a much longer conceiving time.

"Nine months?" Lan Yingying raised her eyebrows.

She then said, "It will take at least a thousand years before I can give birth. Divine Beasts are different. We cannot give birth so quickly unlike humans."

"Is that how it works? But one thousand years... We'll be long dead by then..."

"As long as you reach Spirit Grandmaster, you'll be able to live over a thousand years comfortably." Grandma Lan said to her.

"Perhaps in this world, but alas..." A bittersweet smile appeared on Wang Xiuying's face. Although Spirit Grandmasters can live to be a thousand in this cultivation world, they are only inside a game.

'There's no such thing as cultivation in the real world, after all...' Wang Xiuying thought to herself.

A few hours later, they arrived at the cabin in the Divine Forest.

"Go ahead and make yourselves at home. I'll go brew some tea." Grandma Lan said to them.

After they sat down, Grandpa Lan said, "I will be right back."

He then disappeared somewhere.

"Yuan, what are you going to do once you go back outside?" Lan Yingying asked him.

"Well, I am going to return to my sect for a while. Then I am going to enter this place called Dragon Temple. Once all of that is done, I plan on leaving the sect so that I can explore the rest of the Lower Heavens before I decide to ascend through the Stairway to Heaven." Yuan laid out his plans.

"The rest of the Lower Heavens? That's going to take years, Yuan." Wang Xiuying said to him.

And she continued, "There are four continents in the Lower Heavens, and as far as I am aware, a single continent in this world is as big as all of the continents on 'Earth' combined."

"Really? Then I guess I will just look around until I feel like going to the upper heavens." Yuan said.

"What about following that Senior Nie to Spirit Heaven? You opened the Mystic Pagoda, so you automatically qualify to ascend with him." Wang

Xiuying then asked.

"Nah. I'd rather ascend with my own effort. And there are still things I need to do in the Lower Heavens." Yuan said.

"Makes sense." Wang Xiuying nodded.

Sometime later, Grandpa Lan returned with a small wooden box in his hands.

He sat down in an empty seat before placing the box before them.

"I want you to have the thing inside this box. It's a farewell gift from us—the Lan Family." Grandpa Lan said with a mysterious smile on his face.

And he continued, "You deserve it."

"What is it?" Yuan couldn't help but ask.

"Open it up and see for yourself," he said with a smile.

Yuan nodded and opened up the box, and to his surprise, there were two familiar-looking objects resting inside the box.

There were two crystals— red crystals.

"T-This is... Demon Cores?" Yuan asked in a dazed voice.

"Yes. One of them belongs to the minor demon you had sealed but never got to finish. We finished it for you after your disappearance." Grandpa Lan explained.

"As for the second demon core... It belongs to the Demon Lord."

"Wait... What?" Yuan's eyes widened with surprise.

"Didn't the Demon Lord explode himself? How could his demon core have survived that?" Yuan asked.

"Although it may be called 'Core Detonation', it doesn't actually require the demon to destroy their demon core. In fact, a demon's core has nothing to do with their cultivation, as they store their cultivation inside their body."

"So their blood, their muscles, their bones— every single cell in their body. This is one of the reasons for their near indestructible bodies, as their bodies are made mostly out of spiritual energy."

"If a demon core isn't their Dantian, then what is a demon core? And why does it contain so much spiritual energy?" Yuan asked.

"Unfortunately, I do not have an answer for that question, as I don't know that much about demons, to begin with." Grandpa Lan shook his head.

"I see..." Yuan mumbled.

"Anyways, we found the Demon Lord's demon core at the place where he self-destructed. We were going to feed it to Yingying when she's actually pregnant so that the baby can feed off the spiritual energy and grow stronger, but seeing that you're still alive, we're going to give it back to you." Grandpa Lan said.

"Are you sure?" Yuan asked.

"Yes." Lan Yingying nodded.

"I see... Thank you." Yuan accepted the demon cores and tossed them into his Dragon Spatial Ring.

"Now, onto our next subject..." Grandpa Lan said as his expression suddenly turned solemn.

"Yuan, what do you think about letting Lan Yingying follow you outside?"

"What? Miss Lan?" Yuan's eyes widened with surprise.

"Grandfather..." Lan Yingying was also surprised by his suggestion, as she thought he was only joking back then when he first mentioned it.

After a moment of silence, Yuan turned to look at Lan Yingying and asked her, "Miss Lan, do you want to follow me? I cannot guarantee you that it will be entertaining."

"I..." Lan Yingying opened her mouth, but she didn't continue, and she turned to look at her grandparents with a hesitant look, clearly reluctant to leave them behind.

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Chapter 384 - Leaving The Mystic Realm

"Why are you hesitating now, Yingying? Forget about us old folks and go have fun with the youngsters. You'll definitely enjoy the outside world more than this forest." Grandpa Lan said to her.

"Furthermore, you'll conceive his child in the future. It would be better for the child if the father is there during birth, don't you think so as well?" Grandma Lan added.

"What about my duty?" Lan Yingying asked.

"You're worried about that? Just leave it to us. We will continue to clean the Lord's tablet." Grandpa Lan said.

After a slight pause, he continued with a smile on his face, "In fact, starting today, you have a new 'Lord'."

"Wait... What?" Lan Yingying looked at him with wide eyes.

"Go ahead and serve the young man as your new 'Lord'. You're not bound by a contract, anyway. It was our ancestors who decided to follow the Lord. We're simply carrying out their duties as a family tradition." Grandpa Lan said to her.

"..."

After a long moment of silence, Lan Yingying stood up from her seat and walked to the side of the table where Yuan was sitting.

"Miss Lan?" Yuan looked at her with raised eyebrows.

"Yuan..."

Lan Yingying lowered her body until she was on her knees.

"No... Please allow me to call you my Lord." Lan Yingying said as she lowered her head until it was kissing the floor.

"I wish to serve you as my Lord." Lan Yingying repeated since Yuan didn't respond for a moment, mostly because he was speechless.

"A-Are you sure?" Yuan asked her.

"I am positive." Lan Yingying nodded her head with a resolute expression on her face.

"Okay. If you want to follow me, there's no reason for me to refuse." Yuan easily agreed.

"Really? You don't mind?" Lan Yingying's eyes flickered with excitement.

"Why would I mind? It's not like I dislike you. In fact, I really like you." Yuan said with a smile on his face.

"Great! Now let's make this official with a contract!" Grandpa Lan said a moment later.

"You just need some of my blood, right?" Yuan asked her, as this is what Feng Yuxiang needed.

Lan Yingying nodded.

"Okay."

Yuan retrieved the Starry Abyss, opened a wound on his finger, before finally offering it to Lan Yingying.

Lan Yingying gladly accepted his hand and opened her mouth, putting his finger inside a moment later to suck his blood.

Wang Xiuying swallowed nervously from the background, her face slightly flushed with redness, as this scene looked kind of erotic for some reason.

[Divine Serpent 'Lan Yingying' has initiated a servant contract with you!]

"My Lord, this subordinate shall follow you forever and swear my loyalty to you." Lan Yingying said to him.

"Just call me Yuan, Miss Lan," Yuan said to her.

"I cannot." Lan Yingying shook her head.

"Young man, we take our tradition very seriously." Grandpa Lan said to him.

"It'll be easier on her if you let her address you as 'Lord'." Grandma Lan also said.

Yuan nodded his head, "Fine. Call me whatever makes you feel comfortable, Miss Lan."

"Young man, you should stop calling her 'Miss Lan'. It makes you sound distant from her. Just call her Yingying like we do." Grandpa Lan then said.

"Okay. Yingying, I will accept you as my servant." Yuan said.

Ding!

[You have accepted Divine Serpent 'Lan Yingying' as your Servant!]

Name: Lan Yingying

Servant Grade: Ancient

Master: Yuan

Cultivation: Ninth Level Spirit Master

Legacy: None

Bloodline: Sacred Serpent Bloodline

Physique: World Eater Physique

—

[Sacred Fire]

[Rank: Ancient]

[Mastery Level: 3]

—

[Superior Sense]

[Rank: Heaven]

—

[Devour]

[Rank: Ancient]

—

[Unlimited Growth]

[Rank: ???]

'Yingying is an Ancient-grade Divine Beast? That's even higher than Feng Feng, who's a phoenix! And she has so many Ancient rank skills!' Yuan was inwardly surprised when he saw Lan Yingying's stats.

'And what's this Unlimited Growth skill? I cannot see its rank, just like Feng Feng's Cursed Bloodline...'

"The contract is completed," Yuan said to her a moment later.

"Welcome to the team. I will introduce you to the others once we go outside."

"Okay!" Lan Yingying nodded with a blissful expression on her face.

"Ahhh... How they grow up so quickly..." Grandma Lan said with a smile on her face.

And she continued, "Let's all drink the tea before it gets cold."

Thus, they sat down around the table and began drinking her tea.

Meanwhile, outside the Mystic Realm, an announcement appeared in the sky.

[Congratulations! Player Yuan has become the first player to obtain an Ancient grade Servant!]

This announcement shocked every player currently online. In fact, many of these players are learning about the existence of Ancient grade for the first time because of this announcement!

"Ancient grade servant..." Meixiu stared at the grand announcement in the sky with a dazed look on her face.

"What's the matter, Meixiu?" Feng Yuxiang asked her after noticing her blank stares into the sky.

"Yuan... He just obtained another servant." Meixiu said to her.

"What?! The Young Master?! Is that why I felt a chill down my spine just now?!" Feng Yuxiang exclaimed in a shocked voice.

"What kind of magical beast is it this time?" She then asked.

Meixiu shook her head and said, "We will find out once he leaves the Mystic Realm."

Inside the Mystic Realm, Yuan and the others spent a good hour calmly sipping tea and talking about random things casually.

After they finished all of the tea, Yuan and the others prepared to leave the Mystic Realm.

"Stay safe, Yingying, young man, and young lady." Grandpa Lan said to them.

"We will be here if you ever decide to come to visit us." Grandma Lan said.

"Thank you for everything that you've done for me," Yuan bowed to them.

"Thank you, grandfather, grandmother, for taking care of me. I will never forget the time I have spent here." Lan Yingying also lowered her head.

Grandpa Lan smiled and said, "You can thank us by showing us our great-grandchildren."

Lan Yingying nodded, "I promise."

After saying their final goodbyes, Yuan and the others entered a teleport that he'd created, leaving the Mystic Realm.

Chapter 385 - Mystic Realm Results

After entering the portal, Yuan, Wang Xiuying, and Lan Yingying appeared outside the Mystic Realm.

"So this is the outside world..." Lan Yingying mumbled in a dazed voice as she looked at the desolate area and the people gathered outside.

Meanwhile, Yuan and Wang Xiuying were bombarded with notifications.

[You have obtained a massive amount of spiritual energy from the Mystic Realm!]

[You have enough Qi for a breakthrough]

[You have reached Second Level Spirit Master]

[+11,000 Stats]

[You have reached Third Level Spirit Master]

[+12,000 Stats]

[You have reached Fourth Level Spirit Master]

[+13,000 Stats]

"..."

"..."

"..."

[You have reached Ninth Level Spirit Master]

[+18,000 Stats]

Yuan's cultivation stopped at the peak of Spirit Master after leaving the Mystic Realm whilst Wang Xiuying's cultivation entered fifth level Spirit Warrior.

As for Lan Yingying, her cultivation base remained the same.

"Brother Yuan!"

"Young Master!"

Two figures could be seen flying in their direction shortly after they left the Mystic Realm.

"Xiao Hua. Feng Feng. It's been a while." Yuan greeted them.

"Young Master, is it true that you'd accepted a servant?" Feng Yuxiang immediately asked him, and she turned to look at the beauty standing beside him.

"You... You're a Divine Beast?" Feng Yuxiang could immediately tell, as Divine Beasts have a distinct aura and smell that could easily be noticed by other Divine Beasts.

"I am." Lan Yingying nodded calmly.

"Are you okay, Brother Yuan?" Xiao Hua asked him after her initial shock, as Yuan's cultivation base suddenly leaped all the way to the peak of Spirit Master.

"Yes, I am fine." Yuan nodded.

Sometime later, Senior Nie approached them and said, "Sorry to intrude on your reunion, but I would like to announce the results. Please go back to

your sect in the meantime. And young man, I would like to speak with you afterward."

"Okay." Yuan nodded.

"I will see you later, Wang Xiuying," Yuan said to her before going back to the sect.

"See you later! It was fun playing with you!"

As Yuan walked back to the Dragon Essence Temple, everybody there stared at him with serious frowns on their faces, looking like they were all in deep thoughts.

"Welcome back, Disciple Yuan." Long Yijun said to him after he returned.

"I cannot wait to see the results!" Elder Shan chuckled.

Once everyone was back in their own sect, Senior Nie hovered above them and said, "First and foremost, let me start by saying that this year's Mystic Realm was completely unexpected and full of unexplainable phenomena that have never happened before. In other words, it was an unprecedented experience."

"However, such is the nature of the cultivation world. Therefore, I will continue to rank the sects based on the points the participants have accumulated during the time they were inside, even if it was cut short."

Senior Nie then turned to look at the Mystic Realm and began making some weird hand signals.

"Reveal!" He shouted.

A moment later, a list of sect names and numbers appeared in front of the Mystic Realm for all to see.

[Rank 1: Dragon Essence Temple(9,999,999 Points)]

[Rank 2: Medicine Valley(5,032 Points)]

[Rank 3: Heaven and Earth Palace(1,512 Points)]

[Rank 4: Azure Phoenix Sect(641 Points)]

[Rank 5: Heavenly Melody Academy(357 Points)]

[Rank 6: Grand Sword Mountain (240 Points)]

[Rank 7: Three Poisons Manor(101 Points)]

[Rank 8: Fallen Saber Sect(88 Points)]

[Rank 9: Xianxia Academy(72 Points)]

[Rank 10: Pink Garden Paradise(69 Points)]

"W-What kind of result is that?!"

The Sect Masters there exclaimed after seeing this unexpected result.

How on earth did the Dragon Essence Temple amass ten million points whilst the others couldn't even break five digits?

And how did the Medicine Valley achieve second place, beating the Heaven and Earth Palace that is now kicked all the way to the third place?

Furthermore, there were sects in the top 10 that weren't even top 50 before!

"This year's Mystic Realm— What a mess!" The Sect Masters there shook their heads at the results that were hard to swallow.

Of course, many of the Sect Masters there were unable to accept this result.

"Senior Nie! There's clearly something wrong with the results! Look at the Dragon Essence Temple! How could they have possibly achieved ten million points in such a short time?! The highest points recorded in history were only 10,000 points! Their points are 1,000 times higher, which is clearly impossible!"

"Hmm..."

Senior Nie looked at the scoreboard with narrowed eyes.

Indeed, the results looked a bit ridiculous even for him. However, if Disciple Yuan was the one who opened the Mystic Pagoda which hasn't been opened since forever, it would make sense why they'd managed to obtain so many points.

As for the Medicine Valley, their disciple was following Disciple Yuan, which could be the reason for her unusually high points despite being alone.

"What do you guys think?" Senior Nie asked the people behind the crystal balls.

"Who cares about the results? It doesn't affect us, anyway. Just get on with it so we can take that genius to the Spirit Heavens!"

"I agree. The results are final. There's nothing we can do at this point."

The elders all agreed.

Senior Nie nodded and said to the people on the ground, "The results are final. If you don't like the results, you can fix it next time."

The Sect Masters' hearts dropped after hearing the verdict, especially the sects that used to be top 10 but didn't even make the top 50 this year because someone had killed their disciples before they could earn any points.

As for the sects that used to be top 100 but now within the top 10, they were obviously ecstatic about the results.

However, out of everyone there, nobody was more ecstatic than Long Yijun and the Dragon Essence Temple, as the results had far exceeded their expectations by reaching first place!

"Hahahaha! We did it! You did it, Disciple Yuan! The Dragon Essence Temple has returned to being first again after so long! Hahaha!" Long Yijun

could no longer hold his excitement and burst out laughing.

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Chapter 386 - Picking Three Individuals

Sometime later, after Long Yijun eventually calmed down, Senior Nie said to everyone there, "The Mystic Realm has officially ended. I will now pick three people to come to the Spirit Heavens with me."

The Sect Masters and the disciples swallowed nervously.

A moment later, Senior Nie approached the Dragon Essence Temple first with the crystal balls floating around him.

"Greetings, Senior Nie." Long Yijun and the other sect elders greeted him respectfully.

Senior Nie nodded and said, "First and foremost, allow me to congratulate the Dragon Essence Temple for obtaining the first place in the Mystic Realm."

"Thank you, Senior Nie. However, this is all due to the effort of our disciples, mostly Disciple Yuan, our most recent and talented disciple." Long Yijun said.

"Yes... I can see that..." Senior Nie turned to look at Yuan and continued with a smile on his face, "Would you like to come with me to the Spirit Heaven, young man? You will get the ability to pick whichever of the seven Spirit Academies you would like to join. Furthermore, we will fully support your cultivation path by giving you near-unlimited resources, and we can even guarantee you that Spirit Heaven will not be your last stop."

"Spirit King... No, I will guarantee you that as long as you follow me, you will be able to attain Spirit Emperor in the future."

The other participants watched as Senior Nie extended his hand for Yuan with envy in their gazes.

However, to everybody's surprise, Yuan shook his head and said, "Thank you for the offer, Senior Nie, but I will have to decline your offer to go with you to the Spirit Heaven."

"W-What?" Senior Nie blinked his eyes in a dazed manner, looking like he was in disbelief.

Surely, he didn't just get refused, right?

Long Yijun and the others gasped in shock as well.

"How could you refuse! Do you have any idea how many people want to be in your shoes now?!" One of the crystal balls exclaimed.

"That's right! You cannot refuse this once-in-a-lifetime opportunity! If you don't come to the Spirit Heaven now, who knows when you'll get another chance!"

Sometime later, Senior Nie asked him, "May I ask you for the reason for your decision?"

Yuan nodded in a calm manner and said, "I still have many things to do in the Lower Heavens, so I cannot leave just yet. Furthermore, I want to ascend to the Spirit Heaven with my own strength. I am going to challenge the Stairway to Heaven, after all."

"Stairway to Heaven? Even if you are a heaven-defying genius, it's not guaranteed that you'll ascend the stairway." One of the crystal balls said.

"Indeed. Countless top geniuses have failed while less talented people have succeeded. It's really random. However, if we bring you with us, it's guaranteed that you'll ascend."

Senior Nie then spoke, "You don't have to rush to a decision, young man. I can remain in the Lower Heavens for another week, so you have all that time to decide."

However, Yuan shook his head and insisted, "You don't have to wait for me. I have already made a decision. I will not ascend to the Spirit Heaven— not right now or in a week."

"Hmm..."

A perplexed expression appeared on Senior Nie's face.

As much as he wanted to bring Yuan with him to the Spirit Heaven, it was not as though he could force him.

Even if he wanted to drag Yuan to the Spirit Heaven with him, he wouldn't act so shamelessly even if it's the last thing he does.

"It is unfortunate, but if you don't want to come with me, I will have no choice but to find someone else. Don't regret this decision, young man." Senior Nie no longer paid attention to Yuan and flew away.

"What?! You're just going to let him get away so easily?! Grab him if you have to!" One of the crystal balls said.

"If you want to take him by force, by all means, get your ass down here and try it yourself." Senior Nie coldly snorted.

Meanwhile, the other participants stared at Yuan as though they were looking at a fool. What kind of idiot would possibly refuse such an opportunity?

"Does he not care about his cultivation career? He's even such a genius! What a damn waste of talent! Fuck me!" A feminine voice resounded from the crystal balls, cursing in a graceful tone.

"Are you sure about this?" Long Yijun asked him afterward.

"I am sure." Yuan nodded without any regret in his heart.

After leaving the Dragon Essence Temple, Senior Nie went to the Heaven and Earth Palace.

"Greetings, Senior Nie." The Sect Master and the disciples greeted him respectfully.

Senior Nie nodded before turning to look at a certain individual in the group.

"You. What's your name?" Senior Nie asked him.

"Lightning Emperor!" The handsome young man responded with a smile on his face.

"Lightning Emperor?" Senior Nie raised his eyebrows, wondering what kind of parents would give their own child such a ridiculous name.

But he didn't think too much about it and nodded, "Okay. Would you like to come with me to the Spirit Heaven? I have seen your talents in the Mystic Realm, and they're definitely remarkable."

"I am willing!" Lightning Emperor quickly responded.

"Good." Senior Nie nodded his head before flying to another location.

"Congratulations, Junior apprentice-brother Lightning Emperor, on your advancement!"

"Don't forget about us when you go to the Spirit Heaven!"

The other disciples quickly congratulated him.

"Thank you, everybody!" Lightning Emperor bowed to them with a wide smile on his face.

A few moments later, Senior Nie asked another participant to follow him to the Spirit Heaven, and to no one's surprise, that participant immediately accepted, which should be the normal response in such a situation.

"Now... for the third person..."

Senior Nie swept the crowd with a profound gaze until it landed on a pretty young lady.

He then flew to her and asked her, "Do you want to come with me to the Spirit Heaven?"

"Huh? Are you talking to me?" Wang Xiuying pointed at herself when he noticed Senior Nie staring directly at her.

"Yes. You." Senior Nie confirmed with a nod of his head.

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Chapter 387 - Returning To The Dragon Essence Temple

"Do you want to follow me to the Spirit Heaven?" Senior Nie asked Wang Xiuying again.

Wang Xiuying was speechless since she didn't think that she would get the chance.

She then turned to look at Yuan in the distance.

'As much as I want to stay down here and play with you, I have something more important to do...' she said inwardly.

Wang Xiuying returned to Senior Nie and asked him, "If I go to the Spirit Heaven, I will get to pick a sect to join, right?"

"That's right. You can join any of the seven Spirit Academies," he confirmed.

"Then out of these seven Spirit Academies, are there any of them that focus on medicine?"

Senior Nie nodded and said, "Looks like you'll have a new disciple, Elder Mu."

One of the crystal balls then spoke, "My Spirit Healing Academy is the top medicine sect in the Spirit Heaven that has over ten thousand Alchemy Apprentices and a thousand Alchemy Masters. If you wish to join my sect, you will need to be proficient and passionate in the field of medicine."

"I want to join!" Wang Xiuying quickly said.

"Good. But you should know one more thing. Although you have been given the right to join our sect, you have yet to qualify, as our sect is a bit special, so you are still required to take our disciple examination. Are you okay with that?"

"I am okay with that." Wang Xiuying quickly responded.

"Then it's decided. I will see you when you get up here."

Once Senior Nie has picked three people that will be following him to the Spirit Heaven, he said to them, "Congratulations to everyone that has been chosen. I will give you all seven days to prepare for your departure."

Soon after, Senior Nie dismissed everyone there.

However, right as the sects began leaving, another phenomenon occurred at the Mystic Realm, as people could be seen coming out of the gates!

"W-What the heck? Who are those people?"

The sects there were puzzled by this, as was Senior Nie and the others in the Spirit Heaven.

These people were clearly not participants, so they could only be the natives inside the Mystic Realm.

"Hahaha! It's true! It's really true! We can finally leave the Mystic Realm! Thank the new Master of the Mystic Realm! Thank the Lord!" The people that just came out of the Mystic Realm quickly began rejoicing in their freedom.

Seeing this, Senior Nie approached these Mystic Realm natives and asked them what was going on.

"How did you guys leave the Mystic Realm?" Senior Nie asked them.

"How? The Mystic Realm has a new Master! And this person decided to give us freedom! Now anybody can leave the Mystic Realm!" The natives explained to him.

"Heavens..." Senior Nie mumbled in a dazed voice.

Just who is this new master of the Mystic Realm? And why would he make this change that might affect the world?

'Actually, I can think of one person...' Senior Nie recalled Yuan, who had somehow managed to open the Mystic Pagoda, but he had no concrete proof that he was the new Master of the Mystic Realm.

After answering all of Senior Nie's questions, the Mystic Realm natives left the scene and scattered around the Lower Heavens.

Sometime later, Long Yijun said to the others, "We're going to return to the Dragon Essence Temple now."

Yuan quickly said, "Please wait a moment! I would like to speak with my friend one last time before she leaves."

Long Yijun nodded.

Yuan then approached Wang Xiuying and said to her, "Congratulations on ascending."

"Hehe... It's all thanks to you, Yuan." Wang Xiuying said with a bright smile on her face.

"Unfortunately, this means we cannot play together for a while, but I will definitely go to the Spirit Heaven in the future, so let's play again then," Yuan said to her with his hands extended.

Wang Xiuying shook his hand and nodded, "Yes! I will see you in the Spirit Heaven!"

Sometime later, Wang Xiuying left the scene with her sect and Yuan returned to the others.

"Let's return to the sect now." Long Yijun said, and the others brought out their flying treasures.

"We don't really have enough room for everyone here..." Elder Xuan said.

"Let's talk later, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang said to him before turning into a small ball of flame and going inside his body.

Xiao Hua also entered her necklace shortly later.

The others then looked at Lan Yingying, wondering if she'll be doing something similar.

"Do you also want to enter my body?" Yuan asked her, thinking that she also had the capability.

However, Lan Yingying shook her head and said, "I do not know how to do that. This is the best I can do."

She then transformed into her serpent form, yet it was different from her usual form.

Unlike her large beast form, Lan Yingying had transformed into a small and slender snake before wrapping herself around Yuan's wrist, turning into a bracelet of sorts.

"Wow..." Elder Shan mumbled in a dazed voice, as she has never seen anything like this before.

"Are we all ready to leave?" Long Yijun asked them a moment later.

"Yes."

Once everyone there was on a flying treasure, they took off into the sky and returned to the Dragon Essence Temple.

A few hours later, they arrived at the sect.

"The three of you can go back to your living quarters for now to rest. We'll contact you again in three days." Long Yijun said to the disciples.

"Yes, Sect Master." They nodded.

"Good work at the Mystic Realm, all of you." Elder Xuan said.

"Yes. Great work indeed."

"Disciple Yuan, please wait for a moment." Long Yijun stopped him right as he reached the door.

And he said, "The Dragon Temple will be opened in a week from now."

"I understand. Thank you, Sect Master." Yuan said to him before returning to his own living quarters with Meixiu.

After the disciples left, Long Yijun sat down in his seat in an exhausted manner.

"What an experience it has been..." he sighed.

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Chapter 388 - Recalling His Experience In The Mystic Realm

"Not only did the Mystic Realm finish earlier than anticipated, but everything else is also a mess. We'll have a lot of work on our hands once the news spreads." Elder Shan said with a bittersweet smile.

And she continued, "At least we got first place."

Long Yijun shook his head and said, "Do you really think people will accept the results? Even if they won't say it to our faces, there will be plenty of people who think we don't deserve this rank, especially when the results are so... questionable."

"That is true... Ten million points... I would also question it if I was in their shoes." Elder Shan agreed.

"What can we do at this point?" She then asked.

"We can only prove to the world that we're worthy of this position." Long Yijun spoke with a dignified expression on his face.

"How do we do that?" Elder Shan asked.

"First, we're going to up the requirements to join the Dragon Essence Temple. Although we held a disciple examination recently, we will hold another one while the heat is still at its peak. Furthermore, while some people will question us, there will also be plenty of people who will admire us." Long Yijun said.

The elders there nodded with solemn looks on their faces. The Dragon Essence Temple will no longer be the same starting today.

Once they were prepared, Long Yijun and the other high-ranking sect elders gathered all of the disciples in the Dragon Essence Temple in one spot.

Of course, Yuan and the other two Mystic Realm participants were exempted from this gathering.

An hour later, every available disciple in the sect, regardless if they were busy or not, gathered at the Summit Peak, one of the most spacious areas in the sect.

Over thirty thousand disciples gathered at the place with the majority of them being Outer Court disciples, and they were standing the furthest away from the stage where Long Yijun and the other elders were standing whilst the Inner Court and Core Disciples got the best seats in the front.

"Ahem!"

After clearing his throat, Long Yijun spoke in a loud and clear voice, "You must be wondering why I have returned to the sect so quickly and why I had gathered all of you here today."

"The Mystic Realm had ended earlier than anticipated— it was an unprecedented event."

"Secondly, I am here to announce the results of the Mystic Realm, and I am happy to declare that our Dragon Essence Temple has finally managed to take first place again after so many years!"

"Ooooooh!"

"First place?!"

"Hell yeah!"

The thousands of disciples there immediately erupted with cheering from excitement.

"And in order to celebrate, we will be giving every single disciple extra allowances for the next ten years!" Long Yijun announced, causing the

excitement to skyrocket.

After all, more allowances mean more resources, and more resources meant they get to cultivate just a little bit faster!

"In three days, I will introduce the three disciples that helped us achieve this feat, so make sure you're ready by then."

After giving a small speech, Long Yijun handed the stage to the sect elders and disappeared from the scene to prepare for other things.

Meanwhile, inside Yuan's living quarters, Yuan said to the others, "You guys can come out now."

A second later, Feng Yuxiang came out of his chest and Xiao Hua came out of his necklace. Finally, Lan Yingying unwrapped herself from Yuan's wrist and transformed back into a human.

Once everyone was present, Yuan said, "Let's introduce each other now."

"I will go first." Feng Yuxiang said, and she continued, "My name is Feng Yuxiang, I used to work as a store owner in the Golden Phoenix Bazaar, and I am now a proud servant for the Young Master. Oh, I am also a Divine Beast—a Phoenix."

"A Phoenix...?" Lan Yingying raised her eyebrows. This is her first time meeting another Divine Beast besides her grandfather and father.

Meixiu went next.

"I am called Meixiu, and I am something like a caretaker for Yuan. We've also known each other since childhood."

"Xiao Hua." Xiao Hua gave a brief introduction.

"Nice to meet all of you. My name is Lan Yingying, and I am a native of the Mystic Realm. Just like Miss Feng, I am a Divine Beast—a Divine Serpent, to be exact." Lan Yingying then introduced herself.

"A Divine Serpent, huh? What kind of serpent are you?" Feng Yuxiang asked her.

"I'm not exactly sure..." Lan Yingying said.

"Do you have any special abilities, then?"

"I can summon these white flames called Sacred Fire," she said.

"White flames? I have never heard of that ability before." Feng Yuxiang shook her head.

"How did you meet Brother Yuan?" Xiao Hua suddenly asked with an intensive gaze.

"I met him by chance at my previous Lord's tablet..." Lan Yingying said.

"Allow me to explain," Yuan said, and he proceeded to explain his whole experience in the Mystic Realm to them until he reached the Mystic Pagoda.

"Unbelievable... To think you had to fight so many demons in the Mystic Realm." Feng Yuxiang mumbled in a dazed voice.

Although Meixiu told her about Yuan killing a demon, she didn't know he had to fight so many of them.

"Where did you learn the demon sealing technique anyway, Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang then asked.

"I learned it at some technique store," he said.

"Technique store...?" Xiao Hua recalled the mysterious technique store that had a Spirit King greeting guests at the door.

"Anyways, after arriving at the Mystic Pagoda, we went to the highest floor, where we found a teleport formation that suddenly teleported us to this mythical place called Ancient Dragon City."

Yuan said as he continued with his story.

He then proceeded to recall everything that had happened in the Ancient Dragon City and how he managed to obtain a dragon's blood essence.

"Blood Essence from the Dragon Ancestor?!" Feng Yuxiang exclaimed in a shocked manner after hearing about it, looking completely baffled.

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Chapter 389 - Blood Essence

"Y-Young Master, by 'Dragon Ancestor', do you mean THAT 'Dragon Ancestor'?" Feng Yuxiang asked him in a trembling voice.

Yuan raised his eyebrows and spoke, "Hmm? Do you know the Dragon Ancestor?"

"If it's the same Dragon Ancestor you're talking about, of course, I know him! Oh, but it's not like I know him personally. He's just incredibly famous in the upper heavens." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Oh? Tell me more!" Yuan said, his eyes filled with interest.

Feng Yuxiang nodded and said, "The Dragon Ancestor is one of the oldest Divine Beasts in existence who has existed ever since the Primordial Era—the earliest known Era, and the Dragon Ancestor has built multiple empires and powerful families across the Nine Heavens. He's so incredibly powerful and famous that many people revere the Dragon Ancestor as their god!"

"Many families across the Nine Heavens, huh? I think it's the same Dragon Ancestor since that's what the Royal Family told me as well." Yuan said.

"Heavens... You really obtained the Dragon Ancestor's Blood Essence? Not just his blood, but his Blood Essence! This is a priceless treasure even in the upper heavens, Young Master! I have no doubt that even gods would start a war for it!"

"What's the difference between regular blood and Blood Essence?" Yuan asked her.

"The phoenix blood I gave you is considered 'regular blood' since I can offer it quite easily. Blood Essence, however, requires tedious effort and the

individual's longevity to create."

"Huh? Does that mean it'll take away your life?" Yuan's eyes widened.

"That's right." Feng Yuxiang nodded, and she continued, "Blood Essence requires one to sacrifice their longevity, and to Cultivators, their longevity is extremely important, almost sacred, so you can imagine why Blood Essence is incredibly rare."

"Even true Immortals that have indefinite longevity would not create Blood Essence carelessly because it could affect their cultivation, and that would be disastrous even if they lose a single level."

"I see..." Yuan mumbled.

"This makes me wonder... Why would the Dragon Ancestor risk so much to create his Blood Essence?" Feng Yuxiang pondered.

After a moment of silence, Yuan asked, "Should I consume the Blood Essence?"

Feng Yuxiang instantly stopped her thoughts and looked at him with wide eyes.

"Absolutely not!" She loudly exclaimed, startling everyone in the room.

"I'm sorry for shouting at you like that, Young Master, but you must not consume the Blood Essence because your body cannot handle it. The Dragon Ancestor is a godlike being at the peak of the cultivation world, and its Blood Essence would obviously contain an immense amount of energy. It would be like an ant trying to drink all of the water in an ocean." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Actually, can I take a look at the Blood Essence?"

Yuan nodded and retrieved his Dragon Spatial Ring before taking out the bottle and showing it to her.

Feng Yuxiang narrowed her eyes at the single drop of blood with a pondering look on her serious face.

After a moment of silence, she spoke, "Even considering your abnormal talents, you shouldn't consume this Blood Essence until you're at least a Spirit Emperor, Young Master, because it will definitely kill you in an instant."

"Spirit Emperor? The Blood Essence is that powerful?" Yuan's jaw dropped.

How long would it take him to reach Spirit Emperor? He cannot even imagine!

"Young Master, this Blood Essence came from a godlike being that has reached the peak of cultivation. It's not something a mere Spirit Master can consume. And telling you to consume it at Spirit Emperor is already incredibly dangerous and almost suicidal. I wouldn't tell even Spirit Sovereigns to consume this Blood Essence under normal circumstances."

"I understand." Yuan nodded.

"However, there are methods you can use that'll allow you to consume the Dragon Ancestor's Blood Essence without waiting until Spirit Emperor, and that requires you to dilute the Blood Essence until it's weak enough for you to consume it. Of course, this method isn't recommended, as it'll greatly weaken the effects of the Blood Essence."

"It's okay, I'll just wait until I am a Spirit Emperor. I am in no rush to consume the Blood Essence, anyway." Yuan said.

After all, his purpose for playing this game was never to rush to the peak as soon as possible.

After he finished recalling his experience in the Mystic Realm to the others, Xiao Hua asked him, "Brother Yuan, what are your plans now?"

"I am going to enter the Dragon Temple before I leave the sect and explore the Lower Heavens some more. After that, I will ascend the Stairway to Heaven."

"Okay." Xiao Hua nodded.

Yuan then turned to look at Meixiu and asked her, "What about you? When do you want to start cultivating?"

"Whenever, I guess..." Meixiu casually responded, as she has no real motivation to become a Cultivator.

Sometime later, Yuan spoke, "Since I cannot consume the Blood Essence now, what about these demon cores? I have already eaten one so I know that's not a problem."

He then showed them the two demon cores Grandpa Lan gave him.

"Demon cores? These will fetch good money if you sell them, Young Master. If my store was still open, I'd put these demon cores on the top floor, no doubt."

"I don't need money so I'll keep them for now," Yuan said.

"Hmm..." Feng Yuxiang looked at the demon cores with a pondering expression.

"If you want to consume them like monster cores, I'd only suggest consuming that one." Feng Yuxiang pointed to the demon core on the left.

And she continued, "You'll reach Spirit Grandmaster if you consume that one, but if you consume the other one, you'll risk breaking through to Spirit Lord, which will force you to ascend to the next heaven because only Spirit Grandmasters are allowed in the Lower Heavens... With some exceptions like Xiao Hua, I guess."

"I see... Then I'll just consume the weaker one and breakthrough to Spirit Grandmaster first." Yuan said before taking that demon core and tossing it inside his mouth.

Xiao Hua and Feng Yuxiang had a mini heart attack after seeing his sudden actions, as this was their first time seeing someone eat demon cores, and they were not prepared for it.

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Chapter 390 - Taking A Break

[Heaven Refining Physique has activated]

[??? Qi has been absorbed from the Demon Core]

[You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough]

[You have reached first level Spirit Grandmaster]

[+25,000 Stats]

[Your body has cleansed the impurities from the Demon Core]

[Your skill 'Perfect Regeneration' has improved slightly]

[You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough]

[You have reached second level Spirit Grandmaster]

[+26,000 Stats]

[You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough]

[You have reached third level Spirit Grandmaster]

[+27,000 Stats]

Yuan's cultivation soared all the way to the third level Spirit Grandmaster after consuming the demon core.

"Heavens, Young Master. You're almost at my level... At this rate, you'll definitely surpass me." Feng Yuxiang mumbled in a dazed voice as the aura

of a Spirit Grandmaster emitted from Yuan's body.

"Actually, if you consume the other demon core, you'll definitely surpass me. However, if you do that..."

Yuan smiled and said, "I will leave the other demon core for when I don't have to worry about ascending in the Spirit Heaven."

Sometime later, Yuan said, "I'm going to take a good rest before I enter the Dragon Temple."

"Take a good rest, Brother Yuan. You deserve it." Xiao Hua said to him before returning to her necklace.

"I'll let you rest as well, Young master. Call us if you need anything." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Thank you for everything. I look forward to working for you, my Lord. Rest well." Lan Yingying said, turning herself into a bracelet on his wrist.

"What should we do now?" Meixiu asked him.

"We can log off for the day," he said.

"Okay. I will start preparing for dinner." Meixiu said before logging off the game.

Yuan followed her and logged off shortly after.

In the real world, Yuan continued to cultivate his cultivation. Although he took a slight break to focus on the Mystic Realm, his progress didn't slow down too much, and in just a single night, he had a breakthrough, reaching the sixth level Spirit Warrior.

And with this breakthrough, Yuan could feel and move his body slightly better.

'It's only a matter of time now! Perhaps if I reach Spirit Master, I will be able to move properly again!' Yuan used this motivation to help him

cultivate through the night despite finding cultivation somewhat boring at times due to its repetitiveness.

The following day, Yuan decided to skip cultivation online and continue to improve his cultivation.

And since Yuan wasn't playing, Meixiu also took a break, using her time to surf the internet for more information about the game and other things instead.

"There's already 5 billion people on this forum... It was only 4 billion just a week ago, and this doesn't even take into account those players who don't use this forum. This game sure is growing at a crazy rate." Meixiu mumbled to herself.

Although she has seen her fair share of video games growing popular quickly, none of them could hold a candle to Cultivation Online that has more than half of the world's population actively playing the game.

"At this rate, the entire world is going to be playing this game..."

Meixiu began looking through the forum, and sure enough, it was littered with threads about Player Yuan and the Mystic Realm.

[Player Yuan slaughters over 50 participants at once!]

[Player Yuan has obtained an Ancient-grade Servant!]

[What could an Ancient-grade Servant possibly look like?! Click here to find out!]

[Player Yuan refuses to ascend to the Spirit Heaven!]

[Player Yuan takes first place in the Mystic Realm, achieving ten million points!]

The majority of the forum was talking about Player Yuan, which wasn't surprising after what happened at the Mystic Realm, one of the biggest events in the Lower Heavens.

Unfortunately, only a handful of players were able to participate in the event due to the limiting slots, or the Mystic Realm would've been an even hotter topic.

After losing track of time surfing the web, Meixiu was snapped out of her daze when her phone suddenly began ringing.

"Yu Rou?" Meixiu picked up the phone after seeing her name.

"Meixiu! Guess what!" Yu Rou's excited voice resounded from the phone.

"What?"

"My father has announced to all of the players in the company that whoever meets the requirements to wield the Frozen Jade Zither gets to use it!" Yu Rou said.

"Is that something to be excited about?" Meixiu asked.

"Of course! This means I will also have a chance to obtain it!" Yu Rou said.

"But do you even have the time to play the game? Considering your schedule, it'll be incredibly hard if not outright impossible for you to beat the others who have much more time on their hands." Meixiu said.

"Hehe... I kept the best news for last. Listen up, Meixiu. Because of Cultivation Online's massive popularity and potential, there have been a lot of students and even teachers skipping school just to play the game. Therefore, the principal has decided to cut school short this year!"

"What...? They can do that?" Meixiu mumbled in a dazed voice.

"Of course, the principal asked all of the parents for approval, and to my surprise, the majority of parents agreed, since they also want their kids to start playing the game!"

"Unbelievable... How is that going to work, anyway?"

"Well, the school will try to cram all lessons that would've been taught throughout the year into a single month, so starting next month, I will be able to play the game seriously!" Yu Rou said.

And she continued, "You know what's the crazy part, Meixiu? Our school isn't the first to do this! In fact, plenty of schools have already closed due to Cultivation Online! A new era of gaming is upon us! I can feel it!"

Sometime later, Yu Rou asked, "Is brother available right now? I would like to speak with him."

"He should be available since he's taking a break from Cultivation Online. I'll go knock on his door now." Meixiu said.

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Chapter 391 - Family Assignment

"Yuan, are you awake? Yu Rou is on the phone, and she would like to speak with you." Meixiu called for him after knocking on the door.

"Yu Rou? I am awake." Yuan stopped cultivating after hearing Meixiu's voice.

Meixiu entered his room the next moment and placed the phone beside his pillow and the call on speaker.

"Brother?" Yu Rou called for him.

"I'm here, Yu Rou."

"It's been a while since I heard your voice, brother. How have you been doing?"

"I've been doing great."

"That's good to hear. First and foremost, allow me to congratulate you on your victory during the Mystic Realm! I knew you'd crush the other participants!"

"Thank you. It was a great experience in the Mystic Realm." Yuan said.

"I also heard that you managed to obtain an Ancient-grade servant. What kind of servant is it this time?" Yu Rou then asked.

"Her name is Lan Yingying, and she's a Divine Beast like Feng Feng, but she's a Divine Serpent."

"Serpent? Does this mean she's a snake? I'm not good with snakes..." Yu Rou spoke in a shaky voice.

"Don't worry, she won't bite. And she's usually in her human form, so you don't even realize that she's a snake most of the time."

"Oh, she can transform like Feng Feng? That's interesting. Can all Divine Beasts do that?"

"I heard all magical beasts can transform into humans if they reach a certain cultivation base."

"I see... Can you tell me a little of what you experienced inside the Mystic Realm? After that, I will tell you some good news!" Yu Rou said.

"Okay."

Yuan proceeded to recall his experience in the Mystic Realm and the Ancient Dragon City to Yu Rou through the phone.

"Whoa! You got to meet dragons and go to a world above the clouds? I am jealous! If only I was there with you..." Yu Rou sighed.

And she continued, "Yet that Wang girl... Ah, forget it. I will make up for it in a month."

"Hm? What are you talking about?" Yuan asked her.

"Hehe! Guess what, brother. My school will be closing early due to too many students skipping school to play Cultivation Online! Therefore, starting next month, I will be able to play every day!" Yu Rou revealed.

"What? They can do that?" Yuan was dumbfounded by this.

"Apparently."

"What are your plans now that there's no school?" Yuan asked her.

"I am going to play Cultivation Online seriously and try to be the first to obtain enough stats to use the Frozen Jade Zither." Yu Rou said.

"The Frozen Jade Zither?"

"Yes. Father said whoever gets enough stats to wield it gets to use it." Yu Rou said.

"I see..."

"The requirements... I will probably need to be around Spirit Master before I can wield it, right?"

"Considering the requirements, yes..."

"Brother, since you're number one when it comes to cultivation, do you have any tips for your cute little sister that'll help me cultivate faster?" Yu Rou asked him.

"Honestly, I don't even cultivate normally according to Xiao Hua and the others. I consume monster cores to increase my cultivation, but that's only possible because of my unique physique. As for normal players like you, I think the best thing to do is find a superior cultivation technique." Yuan said.

"I see... A superior cultivation technique, huh? Looks like I will have to either buy it from the auction house or something..." Yu Rou sighed.

"Huh? You're going to buy it from the auction house? Why?" Yuan immediately asked.

"Well, that's where most people get their desired items nowadays, not to mention the marketplace. Do you have any idea how difficult it is to obtain techniques and treasures in the game? You might not be aware since you're blessed by the gods in that game, we ordinary players have to slave ourselves to obtain even an ordinary technique. Luckily for me, I have some cash saved up, so I should be able to buy a decent cultivation technique.'

"Yu Rou, let's not be hasty and waste your money. If you need a good cultivation technique, I will try to find one for you— and it'll be free." Yuan said.

"R-Really?!" Yu Rou's excited voice quickly resounded.

"Yes. I am going to help Meixiu find her cultivation technique after the Dragon Temple. At that time, I will try to look for one for you as well."

"Thank you, brother! Muah!" Yu Rou kissed him through the phone.

"Anyways, I am going to go now. Because the school will be closing early, they are going to cramp all of the lessons together, meaning I will be busier than ever. See you later, brother! You too, Meixiu!"

Yu Rou hung up shortly after.

Once Yu Rou left, Yuan returned to his cultivation whilst Meixiu continued spending her time on the internet.

Meanwhile, inside Cultivation Online, a young lady knocked on the doors to Yuan's living quarters and patiently waited for him to come out.

However, when nobody showed up even many minutes later, the young lady turned around and left his place, returning to her own home that was only next door.

"I wanted to congratulate him for taking first place in the Mystic Realm, but alas..." Min Li sighed.

After spending some time inside her own room, Min Li noticed her communication jade slip trembling. Somebody was trying to send a message to her.

She activated the communication jade slip to hear the message.

"Min Li, our parents have ordered you to meet with this 'Disciple Yuan' from the Dragon Essence Temple and make him join the Min Family! Even

if he already belongs to another family, do whatever you must to make him join us!"

Min Li was speechless after listening to this message that came from one of her elder brothers.

The family has assigned her to make Disciple Yuan join the Min Family? They must have heard about his achievements in the Mystic Realm.

"What a headache..." she sighed.

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Chapter 392 - Looking For Disciple Yuan

On the second day of Yuan's break, Min Li tried to knock on his door again after her failed attempt the previous day, but alas, nobody answered.

"Could he be at the Dragon Pavilion?"

Thinking this, Min Li went to the Dragon Pavilion to find him.

"Good morning, Fairy Min!"

"Fairy Min, where are you going today?"

On her way to the Dragon Pavilion, the other disciples would approach her in hopes for something— anything at all.

Once she'd arrived at the Dragon Pavilion, the disciples there also approached her, almost like she was a celebrity or something.

"Fairy Min, are you here to dine today? It's on me!"

"Why don't you come with us, Fairy Min?"

"I'm just here to look around." Min Li said as she walked around the Dragon Pavilion, hoping to see a masked individual sitting at one of the tables.

Unfortunately, she was unable to find Disciple Yuan anywhere in the Dragon Pavilion, so she decided to give up for the day and return to her own room to practice her cultivation.

However, not long into her cultivation, Min Li felt her communication jade slip tremble again.

"Have you spoken to Disciple Yuan yet? Our parents said they need you to report to them your progress every day." Her elder brother asked her.

"Not yet. He's currently unavailable, so I cannot find him, much less speak with him." Min Li relayed this message back to her elder brother.

Not even a minute later, another message arrived.

"I don't want to hear any excuses! Every minute you're not speaking with him is every minute you're giving our competitors! Our parents really want Disciple Yuan! You know what will happen if you disappoint them, right?!"

"What am I supposed to do if he's not home and I don't know where to find him?" Min Li asked.

"Then find someone who does!"

Min Li sighed, and she stopped her cultivation to go outside.

"Besides the Sect Master, who might know Disciple Yuan's location? It's not like I can just request an audience with the Sect Master to ask about Disciple Yuan..." Min Li sighed again.

"Oh, right. Xuan Wuhan might know something since she's Elder Xuan's granddaughter."

Thus, Min Li went to look for Xuan Wuhan in the Core Disciple's area.

Normally, Outer Court disciples cannot go inside the Inner Court unless they were on a mission, but considering Min Li's background, who would dare to refuse her entry?

After reaching Xuan Wuhan's living quarters, she knocked on the doors.

A few moments later, Xuan Wuhan came outside.

"Disciple Min? What are you doing here?" Xuan Wuhan asked her.

"Sorry if I am bothering you, but do you happen to know where Disciple Yuan is? I need to speak with him about some urgent matters." Min Li said.

"Urgent matters? I don't know, but I can ask my grandpa. Give me a moment." Xuan Wuhan said before taking out her communication jade slip and sending Elder Xuan a message.

A minute later, Elder Xuan responded.

"Disciple Yuan should be resting inside his living quarters. He didn't check out of the sect or anything since we returned from the Mystic Realm. I can try sending him a message."

A few minutes later, Elder Xuan messaged Xuan Wuhan again, "Unfortunately, Disciple Yuan isn't responding. He's most likely busy right now."

"There you have it." Xuan Wuhan said.

"I see... Thank you for your help." Min Li said before turning around in a dejected manner.

Xuan Wuhan raised her eyebrows after seeing her gloomy mood, and she asked, "Did something happen? What's this urgent matter you need to take care of? Mind telling me?"

"It's just some family business..." Min Li said.

"The Min Family?"

After pondering for a moment, Xuan Wuhan realized something.

"Oh, I see... Your family is trying to recruit Disciple Yuan into their family after what happened at the Mystic Realm, huh? I totally understand. An 18-year-old who'd managed to reach Spirit Master... I would also want him for myself if I was part of the Seven Legacy Families."

"You don't understand a thing, Disciple Xuan, and I don't mean any offense. I have been assigned by my parents to recruit Disciple Yuan, and if I do not achieve this goal, they might kick me out of the family, and that's the least of my concerns."

"Being part of the Seven Legacy Families may seem nice and all from the outside, but they don't know how much we have to struggle to receive even the slightest recognition from our own family. Meanwhile, if we make even the slightest mistake, all hell would break loose and everyone in the family will look at you like they have a grudge against you. Perfection— this is what keeps the Seven Legacy Families at the top."

Xuan Wuhan was speechless after hearing Min Li's words.

"Well... I highly doubt Disciple Yuan would join any of the Seven Legacy Families, so what are you going to do?" Xuan Wuhan asked her.

"Prepare for the worse, I guess." Min Li shrugged.

"I mean... If you tell Disciple Yuan about your situation, maybe he'll help you out. He's that type of person, too."

Min Li shook her head, "While that's true, I don't want to take advantage of his kindness. Although I may be desperate, I am not that desperate..."

"I can only say good luck to you, Disciple Min." Xuan Wuhan said to her.

"Thank you..."

Min Li disappeared from the Inner Court shortly after, and she returned to Yuan's living quarters.

After knocking on his doors again, Min Li proceeded to sit in front of his doorsteps.

'Guess I'll have to sit here until he returns...' Min Li sighed inwardly as she began cultivating in front of Yuan's doorstep.

Time passed quickly, and in the blink of an eye, three days have passed since the Mystic Realm ended.

After eating breakfast made by Meixiu, Yuan waited for her to finish cleaning the dishes before they entered the game together.

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Chapter 393 - A Strict Family

Once they returned to the game, Yuan could feel the communication jade slip Elder Xuan gave him tremble.

"Disciple Yuan, where are you right now?"

"Uhh... I am inside my room." Yuan responded.

A few moments later, Elder Xuan responded, "That was yesterday's message. I guess you were absorbed in cultivation or something." Elder Xuan said.

"Were you looking for me?" Yuan then asked.

"I am not the one who was looking for you. It was Disciple Min that wanted to speak with you." Elder Xuan said to him.

"Disciple Min? Why?"

"No clue, but it sounded like she really needed to speak with you."

"I understand. I will speak with her."

"Oh, right. The Sect Master said to gather at the Summit Peak this afternoon for your rewards."

"Okay. I will be there."

Sometime later, Yuan said, "I know we just ate, but I want to eat some more food at the Dragon Pavilion since it feels like it's been so long since I last tasted their food."

Meixiu didn't say anything and merely nodded.

The two of them left the house shortly after, and to their surprise, there was a person sitting in front of their doorstep.

Yuan raised his eyebrows as he called out, "Disciple Min? What are you doing? Why are you sitting there?"

"Eh?" Min Li stopped cultivating and turned around to see a masked figure and a beautiful young lady standing behind her.

"D-Disciple Yuan?" She mumbled.

"Yes?"

"Y-You... You have been inside the entire time? Did you not hear my knocking?"

"Sorry, I just came back..." Yuan shook his head.

And he continued, "I hope you didn't wait for too long..."

"Not long. Only for two days." Min Li said as she stood up.

"Anyways, don't worry about it. It's not your fault that I suddenly need to speak with you. I'm just glad that I don't have to wait a week to speak with you."

"Did something happen?" Yuan then asked.

Min Li nodded and said, "It's about my family, but let's talk somewhere more private if you don't mind."

"We were about to go to the Dragon Pavilion for some food before the gathering."

"Sounds good." Min Li said, and then she turned to look at Meixiu.

"She doesn't look like a disciple..."

"Oh, right. This is my friend and caretaker— Meixiu. I hope you don't mind having her with us. And this is a fellow disciple— Min Li." Yuan introduced them to each other.

"Hello," Meixiu said to her in a calm manner.

"H-Hello... I don't mind." Min Li said, feeling a little awkward.

Sometime later, they arrived at the Dragon Pavilion.

After taking a seat in their usual spot and ordering their food, Yuan asked Min Li, "So what happened to your family?"

Min Li released a sigh before she spoke, "Do you remember our conversation before? About you joining my family?"

"Yes, I do." Yuan nodded.

"Well, now that my family knows of your existence because of the Mystic Realm, they have officially assigned me to recruit you into my family, and they have been bugging me since then."

"I see... so this is about that matter."

"I haven't told my family that I already tried to recruit you, so they're unaware of that for now. However, I am also scared to tell them that I had failed, as failure isn't accepted in the Min Family."

"You see, being one of the Seven Legacy Families, our parents' expectations for us are extremely high. In their eyes, anything besides perfect is unacceptable, and failure is worse than death in some cases."

"What a strict family... But I can somehow relate..." Yuan sighed.

"Disciple Yuan, I know you don't want to join any families, but can you at the very least follow me back to the Min Family so they won't blame me too much for not being able to recruit you?" Min Li then asked him.

"If I don't show any results, they'll turn me into a laughing stock before selling me to another family! Please! I am begging you!"

Min Li lowered her head and spoke in a pleading voice.

"Please raise your head, Disciple Min. I just have to meet your family and tell them I don't want to join their family, right? I don't mind. However, I won't be able to meet them right now."

"T-That's fine! I think!" Min Li said.

"When will you be able to meet them?" She then asked.

"I don't know, but it will have to be after I leave the Dragon Essence Temple."

"Wait... You're going to leave the sect? Why?" Min Li stared at him with wide eyes.

"I only joined the sect for the experience, and I think I already have plenty," he said.

"When are you planning to leave? And what are you going to do afterward?"

"Well, I still have something to do in the sect, but I have no idea when I will finish it. Though, it's supposed to start in four days. After I leave the sect, I am going to explore the Lower Heavens some more before I ascend to Spirit Heaven through the Stairway to Heaven."

Min Li was speechless. Of course, she has heard about Yuan refusing to follow Senior Nie back to Spirit Heaven. To think he'd rather climb to the next realm through his own efforts and not with the help of someone else, she cannot help but admire him for that, especially since she has been relying on her own family this entire time.

'If I had even a portion of his resolve, perhaps I wouldn't need to rely on the Min Family to ascend...' she thought to herself.

Sometime later, the food they had ordered many minutes ago finally started to fill the table.

"Please enjoy your meal, Seniors! If you need anything, I will be right over there!" A familiar face said to them.

"Thank you, Disciple Chu," Yuan said to him.

"Let's talk more about your situation later, Disciple Min. For now, we should enjoy the food."

"Okay." Min Li nodded, and they began eating the food shortly after.

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Chapter 394 - Golden Dragon Badge

"Mmm... Every time I come here, there is something new on the menu, and they always taste amazing. I am going to miss this place the most when I leave the sect." Yuan said after swallowing the last bite.

Hearing Yuan's words, Min Li didn't know whether to laugh or cry. He would be the only person in the sect who would say such a word.

At the end of their meal, right as they were about to leave, Min Li's communication jade slip suddenly trembled.

Min Li expected to hear a message from her elder brother, but to her surprise, it was her father who messaged her.

"What is your progress with recruiting Disciple Yuan? We have received information that the other families have already sent people to the Dragon Essence Temple to recruit him! We cannot waste any more time!"

Although it was a simple question, Min Li didn't dare to respond so casually.

"Greetings, esteemed father. I have just spoken with Disciple Yuan, and he has agreed to come to the Min Family for a meeting."

A moment later, her father responded.

"Just a meeting? Your mission is to recruit Disciple Yuan into our family! We don't need any less than that! Min Li, you are currently the least accomplished in the family, and we have given you this chance to redeem

yourself! Do whatever you must to secure him, even if you have to use your body!"

"..."

Min Li bit her lips after hearing her father's words that essentially told her to sacrifice her body in order to secure Yuan. Even though she gave Yuan the same offer previously, it still felt bitter to hear it coming from her own parents.

"If you cannot even accomplish such a simple task, then you're worthless to us! We might as well give you to the other families at that point! At least you'll be worth something at that time!"

"I understand, esteemed father... I will speak with Disciple Yuan again..." Min Li said before sending the message back.

She then looked at Yuan, who was sitting beside her with a deep frown on his face, as he'd heard everything just now.

"And here I thought I had the worst parents in the world..." Yuan mumbled in a voice of disbelief.

"What should I do now, Disciple Yuan? My parents won't accept anything less than you joining the family..." she sighed.

"Well... Any chance of me joining your family just disappeared... no offense to you..." Yuan said to her.

"I don't blame you. Hell, I would leave this family if I could, but unfortunately, I don't think I have the capabilities to ascend to the Spirit Heaven without their help." Min Li sighed.

"That's nonsense!" Yuan suddenly said, and he continued, "You won't know that unless you try!"

"Thank you, Disciple Yuan." Min Li said with a bittersweet smile on her face.

Suddenly, Min Li's communication jade slip trembled again. However, she was not the only one, as it was happening to every disciple in the sect at this moment.

"All disciples in the sect will gather at the Summit Peak in 30minutes! Don't you dare be late!" Long Yijun's voice resounded from the jade slip.

"Let's continue this talk afterward," Yuan said to her.

"Okay." She nodded.

A few moments later, Yuan wore his mask and left the Dragon Pavilion with Min Li and Meixiu.

Of course, since the Sect Master commanded all disciples to be at the gathering, this included the disciples working at the Dragon Pavilion, which meant they had to close the place down temporarily.

In fact, every single building in the Dragon Essence Temple had to close its doors temporarily for this gathering.

Half an hour later, tens of thousands of disciples gathered at the Summit Peak.

"Thank you all for coming here. Although we already had a gathering three days ago, that was done without the participants who participated in the Mystic Realm. Today, we will have another gathering in honor of those three participants who helped our Dragon Essence Temple achieve first place!"

"Core Disciple Gao, Core Disciple Xue, and last but not least, Disciple Yuan, please come to the stage!"

Long Yijun called them out.

A few moments later, three people could be seen walking onto the stage before standing next to each other in a line.

The first was Gao Dongya, a handsome young man who was renowned for his crazy cultivation talents. The second was Xue Jiye, an up-and-coming beauty who was also famous for her talents.

The third person was Yuan, who was still wearing his mask. As for his clothing, he'd changed back into his Inner Court disciples' uniform.

"Why is he wearing a mask?" The disciples were puzzled by the mask on Yuan's face.

In the presence of so many people, it was only natural for Yuan to be wearing his mask. After all, there could be other players amongst this large crowd of disciples, and it would be disastrous if he revealed his face that could potentially reveal his identity in the future.

"Today, the Dragon Essence Temple will be rewarding these three young heroes for their achievements in the Mystic Realm!"

"Core Disciple Gao and Core Disciple Xue, step forward!" Long Yijun said to them.

Gao Dongya and Xue Jiye quickly took a step forward.

Long Yijun then stood in front of them and handed each of them a golden badge.

"The Dragon Essence Temple rewards both Core Disciple Gao and Core Disciple Xue the Golden Dragon Badge for their contributions in the Mystic Realm!"

"Thank you, Sect Master."

Both Gao Dongya and Xue Jiye accepted the badges, yet the smile on their faces was completely stiff, almost like they were forcing themselves to smile.

After all, neither of them believed they deserved any reward, as they barely did anything in the Mystic Realm.

However, since they were before so many people and the Sect Master, it was impossible for them to refuse the Golden Dragon Badge, so they accepted it with bitter smiles on their faces.

In their mind, the Golden Dragon Badge that is one of the most honorable rewards in the Dragon Essence Temple was nothing more than a participation trophy for them.

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Chapter 395 - Obsidian Dragon Medallion

Once they'd accepted their Golden Dragon Badge, Gao Dongya and Xue Jiye stepped back.

"Disciple Yuan, step forward!"

Long Yijun called him forward.

A moment later, Long Yijun stood in front of him and showed him a badge that looked different from the ones Gao Dongya and Xue Jiye received.

"The Dragon Essence Temple awards Disciple Yuan for his massive contribution in the Mystic Realm, the highest honor that has only been given out two other times since the sect's founding—the Obsidian Dragon Medallion, becoming the third person to ever obtain it in the sect's history!"

"As long as you have this medallion, your status within the sect is akin to that of a Sect Master, and the disciples must respect and treat you as such! Furthermore, this still applies even if you one day decide to part with the sect—granted that you don't betray us!"

Long Yijun handed Yuan a black medallion shaped like a dragon. Compared to the badge the other two obtained, Yuan's badge was crafted with a jade-like material and shaped like the dragon whilst their badges were just ordinary golden medallions with word engravings.

"Thank you, Sect Master." Yuan accepted the badge with a bright smile on his face.

Despite obtaining many trophies in his life, he always finds it a joy to receive a reward for his work, as that meant his efforts meant something for someone and were not wasted.

"Disciples, give a good round of applause for these three young heroes!" Long Yijun turned to face the audience and said loudly.

The Summit Peak immediately exploded with cheering and clapping, and it would not stop until a few minutes later.

Once the noises subsided, Long Yijun gave a short speech about the participants and the Mystic Realm before dismissing everyone but the participants.

"I have more rewards for you three. Come with me to the Treasury Hall." Long Yijun said to them.

"Give me a moment, Sect Master," Yuan said to him before going to where Min Li and Meixiu were waiting.

"You two can go back to the house first. I will return as soon as I'm done with the Sect Master."

"Okay." They both nodded and left the scene together.

Sometime later, Yuan and the other two participants followed Long Yijun to the treasury hall.

"The two of you can pick any treasure you want from the Treasury Hall. Disciple Yuan, you can pick two because of your contribution." Long Yijun said to them.

However, Gao Dongya suddenly opened his mouth and said, "Sect Master, I cannot accept this reward."

"Oh?" Long Yijun raised his eyebrows.

"As much as I hate to admit it, I— we didn't do anything to contribute to the Mystic Realm's result. It was all Disciple Yuan. Before we could even

reach the Mystic Pagoda, we were kicked out, barely obtaining any points. If it were not for Disciple Yuan, I cannot even imagine what place the Dragon Essence Temple would be right now. I don't even deserve the last reward, much less this one." Gao Dongya explained his reason for not accepting this reward.

'Kicked out? Oh... I forgot about them... I'm sorry...' Yuan suddenly realized that he'd accidentally kicked out his own teammates when he commanded the Mystic Realm to kick all participants out, and he apologized to them inwardly.

"I-I agree with Disciple Gao, Sect Master! I won't be able to accept this reward. If I could, I would even return the last reward." Xue Jiye said to him.

"Hmmm..." The Sect Master looked at them with a calm expression.

After a moment of silence, he nodded, "Very well. And if you're feeling guilty about receiving the first reward, don't be. It wasn't your fault that you were kicked out of the Mystic Realm. It was an unknown phenomenon that none of us could have expected."

And he continued, " And since you won't be picking a treasure in the Treasury Hall, I will give you guys some spirit stones to cultivate with instead."

"Thank you, Sect Master!"

Gao Dongya and Xue Jiye bowed to Long Yijun before leaving the scene.

"You're quite the honorable guy, Disciple Gao. I truly didn't expect that from you." Xue Jiye said to him afterward.

"Hmph!" Gao Dongya merely snorted at her words before parting from her.

Meanwhile, back at the Treasury Hall, Long Yijun brought Yuan into the vault where they stored most of their valuable treasures.

"Go ahead. Pick whichever two— You know what? Since the other two refused to pick a treasure, I will give you three treasures instead of two. If you need help with an item, just ask me and I'll tell you what it does. And you can take your time." Long Yijun said to him.

"Okay." Yuan nodded, and he proceeded to walk around the place, taking his time to look at the description of every treasure inside the room.

[Dragon Flower]

[Tier 4 Medicine]

[Description: A flower that resembles the shape of a dragon. Grants immense strength to the user for fifteen minutes]

[Dragon Ginseng]

[Tier 4 Medicine]

[Description: Requires 100 years to fully mature. Mostly used as an ingredient in alchemy.]

[Dragon Bow]

[Grade: Earth]

[Quality: High]

[Physical Strength Required: 8,000]

[Mental Strength Required: 12,000]

[Description: A luxurious longbow made of Spirit Wood and Dragon Silk.]

As one would expect from a sect with the word 'Dragon' in it, there were a lot of treasures related to dragons.

However, even after looking at every single treasure in the Treasury Hall, Yuan was unable to pick a treasure. Though, it was not because there were

no treasures that caught his attention. In fact, there were too many choices and he couldn't just pick one or two out of thousands.

'I already have enough treasure, and none of the ones in here are better than the ones I already have. I should pick these treasures with Meixiu and Yu Rou in mind since they don't have much.' Yuan thought to himself.

And with that in mind, Yuan went through the treasures in the room. However, instead of thinking about what he wanted, he looked at the treasures as though he was choosing presents for Meixiu and Yu Rou.

'Xiao Hua, Feng Feng, Yingying, which of these treasures do you think would be suitable for Meixiu and Yu Rou?'

Yuan decided to turn to the experts for help. Not only were they more experienced than him when it comes to treasures, but they were also females.

Chapter 396 - Dragon Ruby Ring

"Brother Yuan, what about that Earth-grade treasure that looks like a fan? Yu Rou uses a fan, right? It might fit her." Xiao Hua was the first to give him advice.

'That fan, huh?'

Hearing that, Yuan went to look at the treasure again.

[Dragon Fan]

[Grade: Earth]

[Quality: High]

[Physical Strength required: 5,000]

[Mental Strength required: 10,000]

[Description: 150% increased damage. Lowers the cost of Qi for all techniques when using this weapon by 30%]

"Indeed, this might be the perfect treasure for Yu Rou. Thanks, Xiao Hua."

He then turned to look at Long Yijun standing at the entrance and said, "Sect Master, for my first pick, I want this Dragon Fan."

"Dragon Fan?" Long Yijun raised his eyebrows.

He was puzzled as to why Yuan would pick such an uncommon weapon. Does he use the fan as well as the sword and dagger?

"If that's your choice, go ahead and take it. The Dragon Fan has been sitting in this vault for many years now because nobody really uses the fan nowadays." Long Yijun said a moment later.

"Really? Why?" Yuan couldn't help but ask.

"Well, most cultivators view the fan that is normally small and fragile-looking as a weapon for the weak. Its elegant and graceful appearance also doesn't help because most cultivators would rather pick something powerful or popular weapons like swords."

"I see... That makes sense... But my sister likes the fan, so I am getting it for her."

"You have a sister?" Long Yijun was surprised to hear this for the first time.

"Yes." He nodded.

"She's lucky to have a brother like you." Long Yijun smiled.

"No, it's the other way around. I am lucky to have a caring sister like her. If not for her, I wouldn't be here right now." Yuan said calmly.

"I-Is that so..." Long Yijun was speechless, and he wondered what kind of person she was. After all, the sister of such a genius surely must be quite the genius herself.

After picking the first treasure, Yuan continued to look around.

"What about Meixiu? What kind of treasure would fit her?" Yuan asked the experts.

Unfortunately, none of them knew Meixiu enough.

"Young Master, we don't know much about Meixiu. You should know what she wants much better than us." Feng Yuxiang said to him.

"While it is true that I have known her for a very long time, I don't actually know her very well, as she's usually very silent in the way that she doesn't

talk much about her own desires."

Because Meixiu was trained to be a servant, even if Yuan asked her what she wanted, she probably wouldn't be able to answer him.

After all, as a professional servant, Meixiu was only taught to care for her masters, not herself.

"Guess I will look around one more time..." Yuan mumbled to himself as he walked around the vault for the third time.

"Hmm?"

Yuan suddenly stopped at the end of the room when he noticed a red flicker in the corner of his eyes.

He approached this red light to see a silver ring with a red crystal sitting inside a small red box.

[Dragon Ruby Ring]

[Grade: Heaven]

[Quality: Medium]

[Description: Increases the user's base Mental Strength and Mental Defense by 30 percent. 50,000 increase limit.]

"Sect Master, I think I want to choose this ring for my second treasure," Yuan said to him, feeling a strong urge to take this ring that he had somehow managed to miss two times.

"Oh, the Dragon Ruby Ring? It will greatly boost one's mental strength and defenses. It's a great treasure that even has a legend behind it according to the expert that appraised it."

"Legend? What kind?" Yuan asked, his interest piqued.

"Well, legend has it that it once belonged to the Royal Family of a certain Dragon Clan, and that red crystal was forged with a drop of dragon's blood, hence the red color despite that type of material not existing in red."

"Oh, it was also found by the Founder when he ventured inside the Dragon Temple. In fact, most of these treasures were found inside the Dragon Temple." Long Yijun said.

"The Dragon Temple, huh? My anticipation for that place just went up even more!" Yuan said.

"Yes, look forward to it when you enter in four days." Long Yijun said with a smile.

A few moments later, Yuan returned to look for the third treasure.

'Both Meixiu and Yu Rou have a treasure now, but I still have one treasure to pick. What should I pick?' Yuan wondered inwardly.

He then asked the experts, "Do any of you want something from this place?"

"Xiao Hua doesn't need anything." Xiao Hua said.

"I also don't need anything, but thank you for the offer, Young Master." Feng Yuxian said.

"What about you, Yingying?"

"I am also fine without anything," she said.

Suddenly, Long Yijun said, "If you cannot pick your last treasure, may I give you a recommendation?"

"Okay." Yuan nodded.

Long Yijun then went to pick a treasure and showed it to Yuan.

"You have Soul Weapons, right? This bottle right here contains a special liquid called 'Soul Liquid'. If you pour some of it on your Soul Weapons, it will increase its growth rate until it levels up."

"Oh, this does sound quite useful," Yuan said.

"Okay, I will choose this as my third treasure. Thank you, Sect Master."
Yuan said to him.

"Haha... I should be thanking you, Disciple Yuan." Long Yijun laughed.

"Anyways, I will contact you in four days when the Dragon Temple is ready. Until then, you can do whatever you want."

Sometime later, Yuan left the Treasury Hall and returned to his own living quarters, where Meixiu and Min Li were waiting.

"Meixiu, here's a treasure I picked for you." Yuan immediately handed her the Dragon Ruby Ring.

"T-Thank you..." Meixiu was at a loss for words when Yuan suddenly handed her a ring, as it felt like he was proposing to her.

Chapter 397 - Looking For Solutions

After accepting the Dragon Ruby Ring from Yuan, Meixiu immediately wore the ring on her right hand, as it would draw too much attention if she wore it on the other hand.

Min Li watched their little section with a weird look on her face, and she silently wondered if they were really just 'friends' or something more than that.

"Okay, Disciple Min. Let's talk more about the situation. What would you like me to do for you in this situation? Because I cannot join your family, but if I don't, you'll be unjustly punished by your parents, and I cannot do nothing about it after learning about it." Yuan sat down and asked her.

"I honestly don't know. I have been thinking about it ever since I received my father's message, but I cannot think of a good solution to my problem. Perhaps I was never destined to ascend to the Spirit Heaven. Maybe it's my fate to stay in the Lower Heaven and be treated like an object by my family who will eventually sell me to another family, where I'll be treated even worse." Min Li shuddered at the thought of being sold to another family and becoming their plaything.

"I won't let that happen to you," Yuan said with a stern look on his face.

And he continued, "I know exactly how it feels to be treated badly by your own parents. Although I don't know what I can do, I will definitely do something about it. I promise. And even though you say it's not my fault, it is my problem since I am the reason you're in this situation."

"Disciple Yuan... Thank you... And sorry..." Min Li felt a strong urge to pounce at Yuan and kiss him at this moment, but she restrained herself by crying instead.

"Give me a few days to think about it, okay? I will try to think of something in the meantime." Yuan said to her.

"Okay." Min Li nodded.

Sometime later, Min Li returned to her own living quarters.

Once Min Li left the scene, Yuan laid back on the couch in an exhausted manner.

"What should I do now? Xiao Hua! Feng Feng! Yingying! Anybody!" Yuan cried for their help.

The three servants appeared before him a moment later.

"I told you the Seven Legacy Families are a bunch of selfish people who only care about their reputation, Young Master. I say you should stay as far away from the Min Family as possible." Feng Yuxiang said to him.

"But what about Disciple Min's situation? I cannot ignore her!" Yuan said.

"As much as I hate to say this, Young Master, but you should probably ignore her as well and let her handle the situation by herself since helping her might bring unwanted trouble for you. The cultivation world is sometimes cold-hearted and brutal like this..."

Yuan shook his head and said in a calm voice, "The cultivation world may be cold-hearted, but I am not like that. I may be a Cultivator, but the cultivation world does not and will not define my character or morals."

Feng Yuxiang was speechless after hearing his grand speech that touched her heart.

"I know the pain and stress Disciple Min is feeling right now because I was also mistreated by my parents. Hell, I was even abandoned by my family,

and not just once, but twice..." Yuan revealed this to them.

"What?! Your family threw you away? What kind of idiot parents would throw such a cultivation genius away?!" Feng Yuxiang blurred out without thinking as it was simply that shocking.

Even Xiao Hua had her mouth wide open from shock.

If the world knew that a family had thrown an 18-year-old Spirit Grandmaster away regardless of the situation, that family would become the world's biggest laughing stock in history.

Now that Yuan's talents have been revealed to the Lower Heavens through the Mystic Realm, literally every large family out there including the Seven Legacy Families are trying to recruit him at all cost!

To think one would throw away a treasure that everyone would kill for—even idiots wouldn't do such a thing!

"Is that why you don't like talking about your background? I fully understand it now, Young Master..." Feng Yuxiang said, misunderstanding the situation.

"I used to be a cripple who couldn't even feed myself, and I could only lie on the bed all day long and have someone feed me and do everything else a normal person would be capable of with ease. And being in that state, I was nothing but a burden to my family, so they threw me away." Yuan sighed.

"Oh... I didn't know that... I apologize for my rude suggestion just now, Young Master. But at least you managed to overcome your misfortune." Feng Yuxiang said with an innocent smile on her face.

Seeing Yuan completely functional and a peak talent at this moment, one can only assume that he has fully recovered from his crippled state.

"Well..." A bitter smile appeared on Yuan's face.

He was only functional in this world. In the other one... Not so much. Although he is making progress, he is still far away from fully recovering.

"Anyways, enough about me. Disciple Min is the one who needs help right now. What should I do— what can I do in this situation?" Yuan quickly changed the subject back to Min Li.

"You can destroy the Min Family." Feng Yuxiang suggested again.

Yuan looked at her with a frown on his face.

"Stop joking, Feng Feng. I am being serious here."

"Ehh..." Feng Yuxiang wanted to say that she wasn't joking, as destroying the Min Family would efficiently solve most of the problems.

"I don't kill when I say destroy... Ah, forget it..." She didn't want to anger Yuan anymore, so she kept her mouth shut.

After a moment of silence, Lan Yingying spoke, "Can't she just leave her family? That would solve most of her problems. But if she wants to rely on her family to ascend, there's really no way we can help her, unfortunately."

"Brother Yuan could help her ascend if he really wants to..." Xiao Hua suddenly said, causing everyone there to turn their head and look at her.

Chapter 398 - Increased Difficulty

"Xiao Hua, surely, you're not suggesting the Young Master bring that girl to the Spirit Heaven through the Stairway to Heaven, right?" Feng Yuxiang asked her with a look of disbelief on her face.

Xiao Hua nodded and said, "Brother Yuan, there is one method that allows an individual— or a few to ascend to the next heaven without needing to pass the Stairway to Heaven."

"Really? Tell me about it!" Yuan quickly said.

"However, Xiao Hua must warn Brother Yuan that this method isn't recommended, and nobody does it for a good reason." Xiao Hua said.

And she continued, "A single person climbing the Stairway to Heaven can bring at most 9 people with him, and as long as this person passes all of the trials, all 9 people including the climber will be able to ascend to the Spirit Heaven."

"In other words, Brother Yuan can bring 9 people with him to the Spirit Heaven. However, every single person you bring will tremendously increase the difficulty of your trials, making the already seemingly impossible challenge even harder, and the more people you bring, the harder it will only become, hence why nobody uses this method. You're essentially doing the trials for them."

"Huh? Does this mean I am already bringing 3 people with me because I obviously cannot leave you three in the Lower Heaven while I ascend myself?" Yuan then asked.

Xiao Hua nodded, "Yes and no. Xiao Hua and the phoenix came from the upper heavens, so we can actually ascend through the Stairway to Heaven

without doing any trials. But we're staying down here due to our own reasons."

"What about Yingying? She was born in the Mystic Realm that is in the Lower Heaven."

"Miss snake will have to pass the trials in order to ascend to the next heaven since she was born in the Lower Heaven, but because she is Brother Yuan's servant that's bound by a heavenly contract, she will not increase the difficulty of your trials as much as an ordinary person who isn't your servant would, and she won't take up a slot, so you can still bring nine other people with you including us." Xiao Hua explained to him.

"I see... Indeed, I can use this method to bring Disciple Min to the Spirit Heaven, allowing her to leave her family since she will no longer have to rely on them to ascend. Furthermore, I can even bring Yu Rou and Meixiu with me..." Yuan mumbled as he turned to look at Meixiu.

Of course, he wouldn't leave them behind while he personally ascends.

Everyone there turned to look at Meixiu.

Feng Yuxiang then spoke, "While I understand it if the Young Master wants to support Meixiu and Yu Rou, I don't think I like the idea of bringing Min Li because a single person will already increase the difficulty of your trials, much less three... And what if you decide to help another person in the future? That's even more of a burden on you, Young Master!"

"I think I will be fine even if I support three people. What's the worst that can happen? If I fail the trials, can't I just take it again?" Yuan asked.

"Well... You can... But you can only challenge the Stairway to Heaven once every four years if you fail. And wasting four whole years in the Lower Heaven when you can be improving your cultivation base in a place with better resources... It's truly a waste of time and talent, especially in your case, Young Master. In my opinion, four years of your time is worth as much as 40,000 years to others if not even more..." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Xiao Hua agrees with the phoenix. Brother Yuan's time and talent are incredibly precious. You cannot afford to waste four years down here. It hasn't even been half a year since you started cultivating and you're already a Spirit Grandmaster. Xiao Hua cannot even imagine what you'll become in four years if you continue to grow..."

Lan Yingying and Feng Yuxiang turned to look at Xiao Hua.

It hasn't been half a year since Yuan started cultivating? How is that even remotely possible? Maybe it might be possible in the upper heavens where the spiritual energy is much better, but in the Lower Heavens, such abnormal growth shouldn't be possible.

"Anyways, if I fail, then it is what it is. That means I'm not good enough and I wasn't destined to ascend. It's only four years of my life. However, if Disciple Min fails, her entire life might be destroyed." Yuan said.

Then he realized something.

"Oh, right. What if I ascend to Spirit Heaven alone and then come down to the Lower Heaven like Senior Nie, bringing people with me to the Spirit Heaven that way?" Yuan asked.

"That might not work..." Xiao Hua shook her head.

"Why not?"

"In order to come down to the Lower Heaven— or descending from any heaven, one must acquire the permission to do so by the lord of that heaven, and that is not something you can easily obtain, especially if you just enter the Spirit Heaven." Feng Yuxiang said to him.

"Lord of each heaven? Like a ruler?"

Xiao Hua nodded, "In each heaven— besides the Lower Heaven, there is a true ruler who oversees the entire world. Without his or her permission, you will not be able to descend, and even if you obtain permission, you must have enough resources to come down."

Feng Yuxiang then continued, "Think of it this way, Young Master. That Spirit King who came down from the Spirit Heaven needed help from all Seven Spirit Academies to bring three people with him to the Spirit Heaven. You can only imagine the enormous amount of resources required to bring even a single person, much less three."

"So it's easier to bring them up through the first method, huh? Okay. I have decided. I will bring them up with me through the Stairway to Heaven!" Yuan spoke in a resolute voice.

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Chapter 399 - You Can Rely On Me

"If that's Brother Yuan's decision, Xiao Hua will support it." Xiao Hua said to him.

"Thank you, Xiao Hua."

"I'll go speak with Disciple Min now and see what she thinks," Yuan said before going outside and knocking on her door.

"The Young Master is really selfless, huh? If it were any other cultivator, they wouldn't be so generous. When was the last time someone offered another individual a carry through the Stairway to Heaven? I don't even remember." Feng Yuxiang sighed.

"Sometimes I feel like the Young Master is too kind. It'll only be harsher for him in the future when everything comes falling down on him."

"Xiao Hua won't let that happen." Xiao Hua suddenly said.

Feng Yuxiang looked at her and said, "I don't mean to offend you, but even if you're a Spirit King, you're only invincible in the Lower Heaven, and maybe even the Spirit Heaven. However, anything above that, you won't be able to do anything to help him if he gets into any trouble. In fact, the Young Master will easily surpass us."

Xiao Hua remained silent for a moment before speaking in a calm voice, "Xiao Hua has her methods to protect Brother Yuan even if we go to the upper heavens."

It was Feng Yuxiang's turn to be speechless. Now that she thinks about it, she doesn't know anything about Xiao Hua's background or how she's able to remain in the Lower Heaven despite being a Spirit King.

"Well, as long as the Young Master helps me weaken the curse, I will be able to regain my sealed strength, so I will be able to protect him in the future even if we're in the upper heavens." Feng Yuxiang said in a prideful voice, almost like she was bragging to Xiao Hua that she was confident about protecting Yuan.

Xiao Hua looked at her with a calm look, and she suddenly asked, "What will happen if you restore your cultivation base now while we're in the Lower Heaven? Will you be forced to go back to the upper heavens?"

"Uhh..." Feng Yuxiang was left speechless once again, as she had never thought about this until Xiao Hua mentioned it.

It would be bad if she restores her cultivation base while Yuan is still in the Lower Heaven, as that would mean she'll have to be separated from him.

"M-Maybe I should not drink too much of his blood until he ascends just to be safe..." She mumbled.

Of course, Lan Yingying was completely confused about the situation, as she didn't know Feng Yuxiang or Xiao Hua enough to enter the conversation, feeling a bit left out.

Meanwhile, outside Min Li's living quarters, Yuan knocked on her doors.

"Disciple Yuan? What's the matter?" Min Li raised her eyebrows, as she didn't expect to see him so soon again.

"I have a solution to your problem!" He quickly said.

"Really? Please! Tell me!" Min Li's eyes flickered with anticipation.

"I think you should leave that family." Yuan gave it to her straight and without beating around the bush.

"Huh?" Min Li's eyes immediately widened.

"You want me to leave the Min Family? If I do that, I won't be able to ascend to the Spirit Heaven! At least that is my best chance of doing so!"

She said.

"It's okay, you can rely on me." Yuan then said, dumbfounding her even more.

"What do you mean?" she asked.

"I will help you ascend to Spirit Heaven," he quickly responded.

"H-How...?" she mumbled in a dazed voice.

"I will be taking you with me through the Stairway to Heaven," he said.

"Y-You will? But won't that make your trials much harder? Are you sure you want to bring me with you?" Min Li asked.

Yuan nodded, "Yes, I don't mind. This is the only solution I can think of that will help your situation. I cannot join the Min Family, so your family will definitely punish you for it, meaning your chances of ascending will probably be zero."

"However, if you leave that family, you'll have a greater chance of ascending with me. I cannot promise you that we are guaranteed to ascend successfully, but I will definitely try my best to take all of us to the Spirit Heaven."

"All of us? Will there be others coming with us?"

"Yes. I also want to bring my sister and Meixiu with me to Spirit Heaven." Yuan nodded.

"That's three people... Are you sure you can take all of us through the Stairway to Heaven? I know you're very talented but... three people are..."

Min Li suddenly stopped there and turned silent.

At this rate, she will not only be unable to ascend but she'll most likely get kicked out of the family if not sold to another family, so the best choice was

definitely to rely on Yuan who is currently being called the number one genius in the Lower Heaven by many people.

Furthermore, at least she will have a chance to ascend if she's with him. If she stays with her family, she might not even survive the next few years.

"I... I don't want to be a burden to you..." she muttered in a low voice.

As much as she wanted to rely on him, she had her own pride, and completely relying on someone to ascend was difficult to accept.

Although she has been relying on her family, at least she had to work for it.

"How about this, Disciple Yuan. I will challenge the Stairway to Heaven first, and if I don't succeed, I will rely on you at that time." Min Lin suddenly suggested.

"At least I can say that I tried," she added.

Yuan nodded, "Sounds good."

Min Li lifted her head and stared at the clear blue sky.

"I didn't think I'd leave the Min Family in such a fashion," she sighed.

Sometime later, she asked Yuan, "When do you plan on challenging the Stairway to Heaven?"

"Honestly, I have no idea, but it probably won't happen until a few months down the line. I'm sorry if that's too long."

"A few months only? That's fast!"

Min Li exclaimed, to Yuan's surprise.

Chapter 400 - Let Your Body Do The Talking

"Fast? A few months is fast?" Yuan asked her.

"Of course! I was expecting at least a few years!" Min Li quickly said.

"A few years? That's too long!" Yuan exclaimed.

"I won't even be a Spirit Master in a few months! I cannot challenge the Stairway to Heaven with such a low cultivation base! That'll be akin to suicide!" She said to him.

"Hmm..." Yuan pondered.

"Looks like you'll have to just rely on me in the end," he chuckled.

"It's okay. It's nothing to be ashamed about. There will be times when you need someone's help regardless of your situation."

Min Li sighed after hearing his words.

"Whatever... I guess I'll figure it out when you're actually about to challenge the Stairway to Heaven."

"Now I have to worry about how I should leave the Min Family," she said.

"Can't you just tell them that you're leaving the family? I left my own family without even telling them." Yuan said to her.

"What? You left your family?" Min Li looked at him with wide eyes after learning this unexpected news.

Yuan nodded and said, "Well, they were going to disown me, and I merely decided to leave before that."

"Why did you leave your family— if you don't mind me asking..."

"It's simple— I was no longer useful to them, so they kicked me out. Our families are similar in the way that they both only accept perfection. If I make any mistakes during competitions, even if I won the competition, I would be scolded and punished for it."

"And now that I am no longer of any use to them, they decided to discard me."

"I'm sorry to hear that..." Min Li said to him.

"Don't be sorry. It's not your fault."

"But even if I want to leave the family, it's not as simple as it sounds. As a member of the Seven Legacy Families, I cannot simply leave the family without permission, and most of the time, people who wish to leave the family must have their cultivation base crippled before they are allowed to leave." Min Li said.

And she continued, "If I leave without their permission, I will become a deserter, and they will hunt me down and kill me."

"What the heck?" Yuan said in a shocked voice.

"They would kill you just for leaving the family without permission? How is that even allowed?" Yuan said.

"When you're powerful enough, everything is allowed." Feng Yuxiang's voice suddenly resounded behind him.

"The laws of mortals do not apply to the strong," she continued.

"Y-You are...?" Min Li was surprised by the sudden appearance of Feng Yuxiang, whom she has never seen before.

"I'm the Young Master's servant," she responded in a proud manner.

"S-Servant?" Min Li mumbled in a dazed voice.

"Anyways, I have a suggestion, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang said.

"You're not going to tell me to destroy her family so that she could leave safely, right?" Yuan looked at her with narrowed eyes.

"Haha... of course not..." Feng Yuxiang laughed with a stiff smile on her face.

"I was going to say if the Young Master shows up at their doorsteps and demands them to give you this young lady here, they might hand her over without any hassle," she continued.

"What? That simple? Will it really work?" Yuan asked, doubting her suggestion and completely oblivious to the meaning behind her words.

Feng Yuxiang nodded, "You just need to act a little aggressive and domineering. There won't be any violence if you do it properly."

"I see... That does sound like a good idea." Yuan nodded.

"Wait..." Min Li, however, realized what Feng Yuxiang was suggesting to Yuan and immediately flushed with redness.

"Don't worry, Disciple Min. I will do my best to convince them to let you leave the family!" Yuan said to her.

Min Li gave up and said, "When will you be able to do it? They'll keep asking me for updates until I recruit you."

"Can you stall them? I have to enter the Dragon Temple in a few days so I cannot go too far." Yuan said.

"Stall them? But how..." Min Li suddenly realized something and mumbled, "Wait a second... I can simply tell them that you've entered closed cultivation and that I cannot speak with you until you're finished. This

should get them off my back for a while since they'll assume that the other families would also be unable to approach you."

"Closed cultivation?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"It's when a Cultivator isolates themselves to prepare for a big breakthrough or when someone simply wants to focus on cultivating. It's an unspoken rule in the cultivation world that one cannot bother someone in closed cultivation, almost a taboo." Feng Yuxiang explained to him.

"I see... I will be entering the Dragon Temple soon, and I most likely won't be able to speak with anyone while I am inside, so you can probably tell them that I'm in closed cultivation."

"Alright, I will tell them that later." Min Li nodded.

Sometime later, before Yuan returned to his own living quarters, Min Li bowed to him and said, "Thank you for everything, Disciple Yuan. I will definitely repay you in the future for everything."

"Don't worry about it. I will always be willing to help a fellow friend out." Yuan said.

"A friend...?" Min Li mumbled to herself as she watched Yuan return to his home.

Once the day was coming to an end, Min Li messaged her family and told them about Yuan's closed cultivation.

Although her family was unhappy about it at first, they were not completely unreasonable and did not ask Min Li to disturb Yuan's closed cultivation to recruit him, as that would definitely have the opposite effect.

Therefore, they reluctantly accepted the situation and said to her, "Just because he's in closed cultivation doesn't mean you can slack off! Use this time to prepare yourself and think about what you need to say to him! If you cannot think of anything to say, just let your body do all of the talking!"

He may be a cultivation prodigy, but he's also a man! You were blessed with your mother's good looks, so put it to good use!"

"Yes, father." Min Li responded with a calm look on her face.

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Chapter 401 - Dragon Fissure

After returning to his home, Yuan decided to relax in his own living quarters for the next couple of days so that Min Li's lie to her family would work.

During this time, he would play music on the Soul Ensnaring Zither for the others.

"Wow, my Lord, I didn't know you could play the zither... And you're so talented with it..." Lan Yingying was gobsmacked by Yuan's musical talents that had instantly mesmerized her.

And the more she listened, the more she craved.

"No matter how many times I listen to it, it'll never get old..." Feng Yuxiang mumbled.

Meanwhile, Meixiu stared at Yuan playing the zither with a profound look on her face. It was such an odd feeling to see Yuan playing the instrument again, almost like she had suddenly traveled to the past where Yuan would play some music for her whenever she felt down.

Thus, for the next few days, Yuan would play the zither while surrounded by beauties on all sides.

One day before the Dragon Temple opens, Yuan heard a knock on the door.

"Xuan Wuhan?" Yuan was greeted by her at the door.

"Hey, Yuan. I got some free time so I'm here to congratulate you. I know it's a little late, but congratulations on winning first place for the Mystic Realm and obtaining the Obsidian Dragon Medallion!"

"Thank you."

"Anyways, did you get to speak with Disciple Min? She was looking for you before, and she even came knocking on my door to see if I knew where you were."

"Yes, I have spoken with her." Yuan nodded.

"Is everything okay? If you need my help, just let me know!"

"Everything is fine for now."

"That's good to hear. By the way, do you have any plans tomorrow or the day after? Want to hang out?" she then asked him.

"Sorry, but I will be entering the Dragon Temple tomorrow, so I won't be able to play with you," Yuan said with an apologetic smile on his face.

"What? The Dragon Temple? How lucky... but it's not unexpected, considering your contributions to the sect. I hope you'll find some good treasures inside."

Sometime later, Xuan Wuhan left his place.

"I'll see you after the Dragon Temple, Yuan!" she said to him before leaving.

The following day, Long Yijun summoned Yuan through the communication jade slip.

"Welcome, Disciple Yuan. Are you ready to enter the Dragon Temple?" Long Yijun asked him.

"I am ready." Yuan immediately nodded.

"Good. Follow me."

Long Yijun proceeded to take Yuan to an isolated area in the Dragon Essence Temple.

"This is... an earth fissure?"

Yuan was surprised by the location, as they stood before a massive earth fissure that was miles long and was so deep that one couldn't see the ground from the top.

"This is the Dragon Fissure, and somewhere at the bottom is the Dragon Temple. However, before you are allowed to go inside, you must have a pass."

Long Yijun then brought him to this small hut that was a couple of minutes away.

Inside this small hut was completely empty besides a golden magic circle on the ground. This magic circle was obviously a formation.

"Before I give you the Dragon Temple Key, can you call out the experts? Only one person can carry the key at any given time." Long Yijun said.

"Hm? Does this mean they cannot enter the Dragon Temple with me?" Yuan asked.

"Unfortunately, the Dragon Temple only allows one person to enter at a time." Long Yijun nodded.

"I see... Sorry guys, you'll have to wait for me."

A moment later, three beauties appeared around Yuan.

"Don't worry about it, Brother Yuan."

"Good luck in there, Young Master. Make sure you empty out all of the treasures inside." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Stay safe in there, my Lord." Lan Yingying said.

Sometime later, once Yuan stood on the golden formation, Long Yijun activated it.

Yuan could feel a warm feeling enveloping his body as this golden orb of light suddenly appeared from the formation and entered his body.

[You have obtained Dragon Temple Key]

[Dragon Temple Key]

[Description: Allows you to enter the Dragon Temple in the Dragon Essence Temple]

"Follow me. I'll bring you to the Dragon Temple." Long Yijun said to him afterward.

Yuan then followed Long Yijun to the edge of the Dragon Fissure.

"Let me explain to you how this works before I open the Dragon Temple since you only have a short window to enter the temple once it's opened." Long Yijun said to him.

And he continued, "The Dragon Fissure itself is the entrance to the Dragon Temple. However, you won't be inside the Dragon Temple until you enter the Dragon Gates, and you have exactly 10 seconds to jump into the fissure once I open it. Once you are before the Dragon Gates, it will examine your talents and see whether you qualify to enter or not. Do you understand?"

"I understand." Yuan nodded.

"Good, then I will open the Dragon Fissure now. Remember to jump in when I tell you to."

After taking a deep breath, Long Yijun retrieved a couple of treasures from his spatial ring before tossing it down the Dragon Fissure.

A few moments later, the Dragon Fissure began emitting a golden light from the bottom that gradually increased in brightness.

Once the light peaked, Long Yijun said loudly, "Go!"

Hearing Long Yijun's signal, Yuan didn't hesitate to jump inside the massive fissure that would undoubtedly terrify many people.

Yuan fell and fell without any sign of ending, almost like he'd jumped into an endless hole.

After what felt like a few minutes of freefall, Yuan could suddenly see a world of clouds at the bottom with a yellow and orange background, and what appeared to be a golden temple that had a dragon statue coiling around the entire building.

Right before he landed on the floor, a mysterious power stopped his fall without injuring him.

Once his foot touched the floor made of clouds that resembled the Ancient Dragon City, Yuan approached this golden temple that emitted an unfathomable aura.

As he approached the Dragon Temple, a profound and familiar voice resounded from every direction, "Welcome to the Dragon Temple, human."

"The Great One..." Yuan smiled after hearing this familiar voice.

Chapter 402 - A Monster Has Been Born

"Hm? You recognize this Great One?" The Great One sounded a little surprised when Yuan suddenly mumbled its name.

"Of course. This isn't our first meeting. You probably don't remember because they were all separate illusions." Yuan said.

"Interesting..."

After a moment of silence, the Great One spoke, "Come closer, human. I want you to look into my eyes..."

The eyes on the dragon statue suddenly began glowing golden.

Yuan approached the door and stared at the glowing eyes with a calm look on his face.

The next moment, almost as though someone had covered his eyes from behind, Yuan's vision blackened.

A few seconds later, Yuan could see light appearing from above, causing him to look up.

When he looked up, a massive golden eyeball that was larger than a star gazed down on him like a sun.

This situation made Yuan recall the time he spent in the starry sky inside his mind at the Tablet of Comprehension. However, there were no stars here—only a single eyeball that felt awfully realistic.

"I will be looking into your memories now, human."

Before Yuan could even respond, the Great One's sharp pupil contracted, and it began peeking into Yuan's memories.

"Interesting... You... do not belong to the Nine Heavens..." The Great One spoke in a profound voice.

"Eh?" Yuan wondered just how much of his memories the Great One saw.

"Should I call you Yuan... or Yu Tian?" The Great One suddenly said, bewildering Yuan greatly.

"Y-You can call me Yuan," he subconsciously answered.

"Then Yuan, what do you hope to achieve or obtain in my Dragon Temple?" The Great One then asked, and it continued, "Do you want the treasures inside? Are you hoping to gain enlightenment? Is it my Legacy that you seek?"

"Honestly, I am mostly here for the experience. I am fine even if I don't obtain any treasures inside or gain enlightenment. As for the Legacy, I am definitely interested in it." Yuan said.

The Great One remained silent for a few moments before speaking, "Truthfully speaking, your talents are too high, and the Dragon Temple wasn't created with someone of your caliber in mind, as you would simply clear all of the trials with ease, so I am hesitant to let you go inside."

The Great One normally wouldn't hesitate to let someone enter the Dragon Temple even if that person was very talented, as preventing talented individuals from entering would make the Dragon Temple's purpose completely pointless.

However, Yuan was on another level. He was simply so talented that even the Great One hesitated to let him inside. After all, if it lets Yuan enter, he would, without any doubt, clear out all of the treasures in the Dragon

Temple with ease, almost like taking candy from a baby, and that would be problematic.

"I would normally be ecstatic to find such a talented individual, but you... I cannot see your future."

"Is it abnormal that you cannot see my future?" Yuan asked the Great One, as it should be the other way around— that it's abnormal for one to see another's future.

"The Dragon's Gaze is more than just an offensive technique. It has the capabilities to do so much more if fully mastered, and seeing the future is one of them." The Great One revealed, shocking Yuan.

Does this mean he would be able to see the future if he continues to practice the Dragon's Gaze?

"Anyways, it is abnormal that I cannot see your future. If you were an Immortal or have a unique bloodline, it would make sense that I cannot see your future, but you are merely a Cultivator in the Spirit Grandmaster realm." The Great One said.

And it continued, "There are only a few instances where I cannot see one's future. One, if they're an Immortal or stronger. Two, if they possess the bloodline of a god. And lastly... if they have an unknown destiny."

"Unknown destiny...? I have an unknown destiny— at least that's what I was told." Yuan said.

"That explains why I cannot see your future."

"What should I do now if I cannot enter the Dragon Temple?" Yuan then asked.

"I never said you cannot enter. I am still thinking about how I should handle this." The Great One said, feeling a little awkward, as it has never been put into such a situation before.

"Take your time," Yuan said to it.

A few minutes of silence later, the Great One spoke again, "Since you're only here for the experience, I won't take that away from you. However, you are only allowed to do three trials."

"Okay." Yuan quickly accepted.

And he continued, "What about the treasury room and the Legacy? I was given this key to the treasury room by the other you, and I was even told to obtain the Legacy."

"You may go to the treasury room and obtain the Legacy since you have already earned it."

"I see! Thank you, Great One!" Yuan said.

The next moment, Yuan returned to the cloudy scenery and the Dragon Temple.

"I will open the door for you now. Remember... only three trials..." The Great One's voice resounded for the final time.

Once the door opened, Yuan was greeted by a portal on the other side.

Yuan didn't think too much and stepped into this portal, disappearing from the place.

Meanwhile, somewhere in the Nine Heavens, two figures sat before a Xiangqi board. One of them was an old man with long white hair neatly tied behind his back, whilst the other person was a handsome man with long golden hair flowing down his back like a waterfall.

"What's the matter? Are you ready to forfeit this match?" The old man spoke with a smirk on his face after seeing the other individual not move for a long time.

The handsome man suddenly opened his eyes and stood up.

"What's the matter? Why are you smiling like that?"

"There will finally be some entertainment in the Nine Heavens," said the handsome man.

"What?" The old man raised his eyebrows, clearly puzzled about the handsome man's words.

The handsome man then turned to look at the empty horizon and said, "A monster has been born. I cannot wait to see how he'll affect the Nine Heavens— if he survives long enough."

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Chapter 403 - Guest At The Dragon Essence Temple

"A monster?" The old man sitting at the Xiangqi board raised his eyebrows in a surprised manner.

"That's really funny coming from a monster such as yourself. Who is this individual? Someone from the ninth heaven?" The old man then asked.

"No, he's someone not related to the Nine Heavens, and he's currently in the first heaven—the Lower Heaven." The man with the golden hair said.

"Lower Heaven? It's been a very long time since I've heard of that place." The old man mumbled.

"Anyways, how talented is this individual?" He continued.

"I don't know," said the handsome man.

"I mean I don't know the full extent of his talents. However, if I had to compare him with someone, it'd probably be the Demon Sealing Clan's ancestor."

"What!? This individual is comparable to that monster who ate his way to the peak? How is that even possible? That man is one-of-a-kind and has no equal." The old man doubted the handsome man.

The handsome man turned around with a profound smile on his face, and he spoke in a calm voice, "Who said he was comparable to the ancestor? This young monster might be even crazier than the ancestor."

The old man stared at him with a stunned face, and after a moment of pure silence, he burst out laughing.

"Someone even more talented than that monster who single-handedly annihilated the entire Demon Clan that once ruled the entire Nine Heavens? Have you finally gone senile, my friend?"

The handsome man continued to smile despite the old man's mocking words, and he said, "Don't tell me I didn't warn you in the future."

"Whatever." The old man shrugged, and he continued, "Anyways, what about our match? If you don't want to continue playing, it'll be my victory and your loss."

The handsome man then returned to his seat and said, "My loss? I don't lose — the Great One doesn't lose!"

Meanwhile, back in the Dragon Temple, after entering the portal, Yuan was transported to what appeared to be inside a large city underneath a dark sky that had countless flickering stars, giving the place natural but subtle brightness.

"This is the Dragon Temple?" Yuan raised his eyebrows, as he didn't expect the place to be a city.

However, there was something weird about this city. It was too empty and quiet even if it was late into the night, almost like nobody else was there.

"What should I do here?" Yuan looked around for clues.

The first thing he noticed was the numbers counting down in the sky, and the next thing that stood out was this massive dragon statue very far in the distance.

[167:59:10]

"If the numbers are how long I have left in this place, then I have 7 days to explore this place, but where should I go first?"

After pondering for a moment, Yuan decided to head for the dragon statue, as he recalled the Great One telling him that he would be able to find its Legacy there.

"Once I take a look at his Legacy, I will try to find the treasure room."

With that in mind, Yuan began making his way to the dragon statue by flying there.

And the more of the city he saw, the more clear it was to him that he was alone in this city.

Meanwhile, shortly after Yuan entered the Dragon Fissure, Feng Yuxiang asked Long Yijun, "How long will the Young Master have inside the Dragon Temple?"

"That will depend on the Dragon Temple itself. It might only allow him to stay inside for a few days, or it could let him wander for a whole month. I cannot really say how long he'll be inside, I'm sorry."

"I see..."

Long Yijun suddenly retrieved a small toy-like house and tossed it on the ground. The house grew in size until it was the size of a large house, and it was the same house he used at the Mystic Realm.

"You ladies can stay in this building in the meantime. I won't be able to stay here for too long since I have a lot of work to do. Tell Disciple Yuan to contact me once he comes out." Long Yijun said to them.

"Thank you." Feng Yuxiang said.

Sometime later, Long Yijun left the scene and returned to the sect master's headquarters, where a couple of figures could be seen gathered outside the door.

Most of these people were sect elders, but one of these figures didn't look to be part of the Dragon Essence Temple, and they were even wearing a veil.

"Sect Master, you have a guest!" The Sect Elders there immediately said to him the moment they noticed him.

The veiled figure suddenly stepped forward and lifted the veil covering her beautiful face.

Long Yijun was taken aback when he recognized this face.

"Sect Master Song? What are you doing here?" Long Yijun asked her.

"I'm here to speak with Disciple Yuan," she said in a calm voice.

"You still haven't given up on that...?" Long Yijun shook his head.

Obviously, he'd heard from Elder Shan and Elder Xuan about Song Ling'er desire to take Disciple Yuan as her own disciple after what happened at the zither competition.

"I will never give up on someone with such gifted hands and talent for music!" Song Ling'er said.

Long Yijun sighed and turned to look at the sect elders there.

"You guys can leave. I will handle things from here."

"Yes, Sect Master."

The sect elders bowed to them before leaving the scene.

"Let's talk inside." Long Yijun said as he entered the building.

"I don't want to talk to you. I want to talk to Disciple Yuan. You may be the Sect Master, but Disciple Yuan's decision is what matters the most." Song Ling'er said to him.

"Well, unfortunately for you, Disciple Yuan isn't available right now, so you'll have to speak with me instead." Long Yijun said.

"Where is he then? I can go to him instead."

"That's impossible since he's technically not in the sect." Long Yijun shrugged.

"What? Then where'd he go?"

"Who knows."

"Che..." Song Ling'er sucked her teeth before following Long Yijun inside the building.

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Chapter 404 - The First Players To Ascend

A few moments later, Song Ling'er sat down in a room with Long Yijun sitting behind his work desk.

"So where is Disciple Yuan?" Song Ling'er asked.

"He's currently inside the Dragon Temple," he said casually.

One would expect Long Yijun to keep the Dragon Temple a secret since there are clearly plenty of valuable treasures inside. However, the Dragon Temple has been widespread knowledge for ages now.

"The Dragon Temple? Since when?" Song Ling'er said.

"A couple of minutes ago," he said.

"..."

Song Ling'er was speechless. If only she'd come to this place a day early—even a few hours early, she might've been able to speak with Yuan.

"Now that you know about his whereabouts, you may leave this place."

"Hmph. Then I will stay here until he comes out." Song Ling'er said, surprising him.

"What? You're going to stay here until he returns? It might be weeks before he comes out! As the Sect Master of one of the top ten sects in the Lower Heaven, don't you have better things to do than chase someone who has already rejected you?" Long Yijun said to her.

Song Ling'er looked at his desk that was filled with papers and sneered, "Unlike you, I finish all of my work before I decide to do anything. The Mystic Realm just ended, so I have plenty of time to spare."

"And speaking of the Mystic Realm, your sect only obtained its place because of Disciple Yuan. I cannot wait to see the look on your face after the next one."

Long Yijun smiled and said, "No need to push your anger on me just because you were rejected by a junior."

"Y-You little!" Song Ling'er was immediately aggravated by his comeback.

"Hmph. I did not come here to argue with you. I am here to take Disciple Yuan with me."

Long Yijun shook his head and said, "What makes you think he'll join your sect? He even refused to go to the Spirit Heaven with Senior Nie, you know?"

"I know. I was there when it happened," she said, and she continued, "If he'd gone with Senior Nie to the Spirit Heaven, I would have given up. But the fact that he decided to stay in the Lower Heaven means I still have a chance."

"Keep dreaming." Long Yijun laughed.

And then he continued, "Anyways, if you're not going to leave, you can go ahead and wait for as long as you'd like. In the end, it's Disciple Yuan's decision whether he wants to follow you or not. I would love to have him as a core disciple in the Dragon Essence Temple, but I know he won't stay with us for long. Perhaps after the Dragon Temple, he will leave the sect. This place is too small for someone like him."

"Then I shall wait for him outside the Dragon Temple," she said.

"Do whatever you want." Long Yijun shrugged.

Normally, Long Yijun wouldn't act so carefree before the Sect Master of another sect, but he has known Song Ling'er for a very long time now, and while they were not friends, they were not enemies either.

Long Yijun also knew that Song Ling'er was not the type of person to harm others without a reason, nor was she someone who'd scheme against others, so he wasn't too worried about letting her roam the sect without any supervision.

Furthermore, it was clear to him that she was only here for Disciple Yuan.

After leaving the building, Song Ling'er went straight to the Dragon Fissure.

She noticed a portable house by the Dragon Fissure and subconsciously decided to stay there just in case she wanted to use it, unaware that it was already occupied.

Sometime later, Song Ling'er sat by the Dragon Fissure and retrieved her zither, eventually playing it to pass time.

"Isn't that one of the judges during the zither competition? What is she doing here?" Feng Yuxiang quickly recognized Song Ling'er based on her aura.

"She's obviously here for Brother Yuan," Xiao Hua said.

"What? She's a really persistent one. The Young Master has already refused her offer plenty of times, yet she just doesn't give up."

"Who is she?" Lan Yingying couldn't help but ask.

"She's the Sect Master of the Heavenly Melody Academy, and she was the judge in a competition the Young Master participated in. She even had a little battle with the Young Master and lost to him, and she has been chasing after him since then." Feng Yuxiang explained the situation.

"I see..." Lan Yinying nodded.

Meanwhile, in the Medicine Valley that was in the Northern Continent, Wang Xiuying bowed to her master and said, "Thank you for everything, Master. I have learned a lot from this place."

"No, I should be the one thanking you. I have also learned a lot from you. You are definitely one of the most talented disciples we've ever had. If you continue to study medicine, I'm sure you'll become someone great in the future." Her master said.

"Good luck in the Spirit Heavens."

Wang Xiuying nodded before turning around and walking to Senior Nie, who was there with the other two participants going to the Spirit Heaven with her, and one of them was also a player like her.

"Are you ready to leave this place?" Senior Nie asked her.

"Yes, I am."

"Good. Then we will be going to the Spirit Heaven now." Senior Nie departed the Medicine Valley with Wang Xiuying and the other two, taking them back to the place outside the Mystic Realm.

Once he was prepared, Senior Nie retrieved a crystal and crushed it with his hands.

The next moment, a massive formation appeared beneath them before enveloping them in a warm light.

"This feels like..."

Wang Xiuying found the formation similar to the one in the Mystic Pagoda that took her and Yuan to the Ancient Dragon City.

Whoosh!

The four of them began levitating off the ground before shooting straight up into the sky, where a portal had suddenly opened up.

And before they were aware, Wang Xiuying and the others left the Lower Heaven, becoming the first players to ascend.

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Chapter 405 - A New Era

After Wang Xiuying and the others entered the portal, they found themselves inside this wormhole, and their bodies continued to move upwards.

They remained inside the wormhole for only half a minute before they were met with another portal at the end of this wormhole.

Once they entered it, they were greeted by a clear blue sky and a dozen unfamiliar figures.

"Welcome back, Elder Nie." One of them said to him.

Senior Nie nodded and turned to look at a particular figure in the group, and he said, "Elder Mu, she's all yours."

A pretty middle-aged woman stepped forward and approached Wang Xiuying with a smile on her face, "You're Healer Wang, right? I'm Elder Mu, we have spoken before via the crystal ball, and I will be in charge of you starting today. Follow me. I will bring you to my Spirit Healing Academy."

"Yes!" Wang Xiuying eagerly nodded her head and followed Elder Mu.

"The two of you haven't decided on a sect yet, so that is what you'll be doing today." Senior Nie said to the Lightning Emperor and the other participant.

Meanwhile, an announcement appeared in the sky for all of the players to see shortly after Wang Xiuying and the others arrived at the Spirit Heaven.

[Congratulations! Player Healer Wang and Player Lightning Emperor have become the first players to ascend to 'Spirit Heaven'!]

Of course, the players were well aware of this before the announcement, as the players at the Mystic Realm had revealed this fact to the world the day it happened.

When the players heard that Player Yuan had willingly decided to stay behind in the Lower Heaven for some reason, everyone became puzzled and curious about this reason, as they all thought he was trying to speedrun the game— at least that's what it seemed like to the players after seeing so many ridiculous achievements from him.

Of course, countless news sources approached the Lightning Emperor for interviews after learning that he will be ascending to the next realm which was thought to be impossible until a few years later.

As for Healer Wang... Since only her close friends knew her identity, she was spared from the journalists.

Of course, that is not to say the world wasn't interested in Healer Wang. In fact, a lot of people became interested in her after learning that she was with Player Yuan during the Mystic Realm.

This made people wonder whether Healer Wang knew Player Yuan's identity or not. If she did, she would become their biggest clue to Player Yuan's mysterious identity if not the key to it.

Thus, many people switched from trying to find Player Yuan's identity to finding Player Healer Wang's identity.

Meanwhile, inside the Dragon Temple, Yuan had just reached the dragon statue after flying for almost the entire day.

"Why is the sky still dark? It should be morning by now..." Yuan wondered to himself after realizing that the night wasn't turning into day.

Since he cannot tell the time of the day, Yuan decided to log off early, as he'd rather be safe than sorry.

After logging off and not smelling anything delicious, Yuan proceeded to spend his time cultivating until Meixiu finished preparing dinner.

Once dinner was prepared, Meixiu fed it to Yuan.

"Do you know how long you'll be staying inside the Dragon Temple? Xiao Hua and the others are curious." Meixiu asked him after dinner.

"I have 7 days inside the Dragon Temple," he said.

"A week, huh? Okay, I will let them know."

"Thank you."

Sometime later, Meixiu said, "Oh, right. Wang Xiuying wanted me to let you know that she has ascended to the Spirit Heaven successfully, and she said the world up there is very different compared to the Lower Heaven."

"She's making me want to hurry up and go to the Spirit Heaven to see what's up there..." Yuan smiled.

"Also, I think there's someone waiting for you to come out of the Dragon Temple— besides Xiao Hua and the others," Meixiu added.

"Who?" Yuan asked.

"I don't know her, but according to Feng Feng, she used to be a judge for the zither competition you participated in."

"Sect Master Song? I thought she gave up on trying to recruit me since I haven't seen her since the competition." Yuan said.

After a moment of silence, Meixiu asked, "Why did you refuse her offer? You don't want to play the instrument anymore? But you were having so much fun when you played the zither just the other day."

"It's not that I don't want to play the instrument. As you'd said, I enjoy playing them. However, I don't want instruments to be my focus, and if I had accepted her offer, I'd have to play the instrument seriously again." Yuan said.

"I see..." Meixiu mumbled, as she personally wanted to see Yuan play the instrument again seriously since she felt that Yuan had left the stage too abruptly and far too soon, and it was his musical talents that first captured her heart.

Sometime later, Yuan returned to the Dragon Temple and proceeded to see how he could obtain the Great One's Legacy from it.

Meixiu went to sleep after cleaning the dishes and taking a shower.

In the midst of the night, unbeknownst to Yuan or Meixiu, on the most popular Cultivation Online forum, a topic that would become an instant sensation overnight was created, and this single post would change their world forever and bring forth a new era!

[Cultivation in the real world is possible!]

Although the title of this topic was incredibly simple, it instantly attracted the attention of everyone that saw it, and within mere minutes, the post had amassed tens of thousands of views.

[The cultivation techniques from Cultivation Online actually work in the real world! After many weeks of effort, I have finally become a Cultivator!]

Once the people read the post, they would either laugh at the person who made the post or try it for themselves. And while the results greatly differed from each individual, there was no doubt that some people have succeeded in breaking their mortal shackles, becoming Cultivators in the real world as well!

Chapter 406 - Breaking News

After returning to the Dragon Temple, Yuan immediately began walking around the massive dragon statue trying to find a way to activate it.

However, even after circling around the thing for a few minutes and finding nothing, Yuan took a seat in front of the statue and began pondering.

"Oh, right. The Great One mentioned using the Dragon's Gaze on it."

Once he'd realized this, Yuan quickly stood up again and activated his Dragon's Gaze before walking around the statue again.

However, to his surprise, he wasn't able to find it even with the Dragon's Gaze activated.

"Nothing's happening... Maybe I need to increase the strength of the Dragon's Gaze?"

Thinking that, Yuan pushed his Dragon's Gaze to its limits.

"Haaa... haaa... It didn't work..." Yuan gasped for air a few minutes later, as the Dragon's Gaze consumed an insane amount of spiritual energy when used at its full power.

Yuan collapsed on the floor a moment later and just laid there while staring at the statue that spiraled up as though it was trying to ascend.

"Wait a second... What if the reason I cannot find the thing is because it's at the top of the statue?"

With this in mind, after taking a few minutes to recover his spiritual energy, Yuan flew into the air until he was even higher than the dragon statue,

where he activated the Dragon's Gaze once again.

Almost instantly after he activated his Dragon's Gaze, Yuan noticed a golden glow inside the dragon's mouth.

"That should be it!" Yuan approached the dragon statue with excitement.

However, even though he could see a golden light inside the dragon's mouth, he wasn't sure what to do with it, and putting his hands inside didn't feel right.

After pondering for a moment, Yuan decided to poke the inside of the dragon's mouth with the Empyrean Overlord just to make sure it was safe.

A few taps later, the dragon statue suddenly began rumbling.

The rumbling quickly spread to the city, and within just moments, it seemed as if the entire world was shaking.

"I hope nothing bad happens..." Yuan mumbled to himself as he helplessly watched the entire world shake violently.

The earthquake eventually stopped after a few minutes, and Yuan looked around to make sure everything was okay.

However, he quickly noticed a change in the scenery.

Although the skies were still dark, there were subtle lights coming from the ground around the city that gradually grew clearer and brighter.

If one looked closely, one would see that an enormous magical circle had suddenly appeared around the city.

Furthermore, this formation appeared to be only half complete, as some symbols and patterns looked incomplete.

"What a massive formation... How am I supposed to activate something like this?" Yuan mumbled in a dazed voice.

Suddenly, a notification appeared before him.

[The Great One's Seal of Approval is reacting to the surroundings]

[The Great One's Seal of Approval has activated]

The next moment, a golden orb of light the size of a baby's fist appeared from his forehead.

This golden orb of light then dropped towards the ground, acting almost like a drop of water under gravity.

A few seconds later, the golden orb of light reached the ground and created a ripple effect in the formation before disappearing into the ground like a drop of water in a calm pond.

The formation that surrounded the city began to change, and the incomplete symbols and patterns began fixing themselves until they looked complete.

However, this process didn't finish in just a few minutes, and by the looks of it, it might take hours, even days before the formation becomes complete again.

After waiting around for a few hours without anything happening, Yuan decided to log off for breakfast.

Hopefully, it'll be done by the time he returns, but he wasn't feeling very hopeful.

Meanwhile, in the real world, Meixiu slowly opened her eyes five minutes before the alarm in her phone began ringing.

After taking a moment to fight through her morning grogginess, Meixiu stretched her body on the bed before sitting up.

Once she could open her eyes fully, Meixiu looked at the time on her phone.

Seeing that it was only a few minutes before her alarm, she went to turn off the alarm before getting off the bed.

However, right as she prepared to leave her room to go to the bathroom, her phone suddenly began ringing.

"A phone call? Who's calling me this early in the morning?" Meixiu mumbled to herself as she went to pick up her phone again.

"Yu Rou? What's the matter?" Meixiu answered the phone after seeing the caller.

"Meixiu! Are you seeing the news?!" Yu Rou immediately asked her in a loud and excited voice.

It was so loud that Meixiu subconsciously moved the phone away from her sensitive ears.

"The news? Why would the news be on? It's barely sunrise... And I just woke up." Meixiu said a moment later.

"Don't mind the minor details! Hurry up and look at the news! It doesn't matter which channel you pick! Just hurry! This is massive!" Yu Rou said to her.

"O-Okay..."

Now fully awake thanks to Yu Rou's excited voice, Meixiu went to open her laptop and looked at the news.

The first thing she saw after opening up the news was the large and bold title that read— [Breaking news! Cultivation is real! Cultivation techniques from the popular video game 'Cultivation Online' works in the real world according to many players, and there is even solid proof that it's real!]

"W-What...?" Meixiu mumbled in a low voice as she stared at the title with a dazed look on her face.

Not daring to believe her eyes, Meixiu read the title again and again until Yu Rou's voice resounded, "Are you seeing it?! They say cultivation is real! I just started watching, too!"

"This must be a joke... There's no way cultivation techniques from a video game could possibly work in the real world as well, right?" Meixiu said.

"That's what I thought at first too, but after looking around the forums and the other news sources, everybody is talking about it! There's no way they'd make such an elaborate lie just to mess with us! I think it's true! We might be able to become Cultivators in this world as well, Meixiu!" Yu Rou said, her voice peaking with excitement.

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Chapter 407 - Cultivation Is Real!

"We can become Cultivators in the real world...?" Meixiu mumbled in a dazed voice, feeling a little awkward saying something so unbelievable out loud.

"I repeat, cultivation is real! You can become a cultivator if you use the cultivation techniques from the popular video game 'Cultivation Online'!" The news anchor said in a loud and excited voice.

"However, do keep in mind that while cultivation exists, not everyone can become a Cultivator! It could also take you days, weeks, or even months to become a Cultivator depending on your talents— exactly like Cultivation Online!"

"Furthermore, the higher grade your cultivation technique is, the higher chance you have at becoming a Cultivator!"

After talking for a few minutes, the news anchor said, "We will have a special guest in just a few minutes, and he is a player in Cultivation Online who'd successfully managed to become a Cultivator! In fact, he is the person who made the topic about cultivation being real—the first one who made this world-changing discovery!"

"..."

"Yu Rou... What do you think is going to happen to our world now?" Meixiu asked her.

"I don't know... This might be a good thing, or it could turn disastrous. Only time will tell." Yu Rou sighed.

Sometime later, Meixiu said, "I have to tell Yuan about this..."

"Oh, right. Is he awake yet?"

"I will go check."

"Hehe... Brother will be so surprised..." Yu Rou said.

A few moments later, Meixiu knocked on Yuan's door.

"Yuan, are you awake?"

"Yes, I am."

"We have an emergency..." Meixiu said.

"What happened?"

"Listen to the news, brother." Yu Rou said.

"Yu Rou?" Yuan was surprised to hear Yu Rou's voice as well.

Meixiu proceeded to grab her laptop and replayed the news to Yuan.

"Cultivation is real! As long as we use the cultivation techniques in Cultivation Online, we can become Cultivators in this world as well!" The news anchor shouted in excitement.

"..."

Yuan was stunned after hearing the news.

'So the world has finally learned about it as well, huh? I guess cultivation is real...' Yuan sighed inwardly.

Even though he has been cultivating for a while now, it felt so surreal that he didn't fully believe that he was actually doing cultivation.

Unbeknownst to Yuan, some players have long learned that cultivation in the real world was possible shortly after the game launched. The only reason it hasn't been announced until today was simply because these

people wanted to keep this secret to themselves so that they could get ahead of everyone else when the news eventually spread around the world.

After all, there are bound to be a few people who would try cultivation in the real world after they play Cultivation Online. It was akin to children trying to mimic their superheroes' signature attacks while they watched the television even if they knew superpowers don't exist in the real world.

It was their curiosity that made this discovery.

Yu Rou's voice suddenly resounded, "Meixiu, quickly go back to the live news! It's the person who discovered that cultivation works in the real world!"

Meixiu stopped the replay and switched it back to live news, and sure enough, there was a young man sitting beside the news anchor.

"Can you please introduce yourself to the audience?" The news anchor asked the young man.

He nodded and spoke in a clear voice, "Hello, my name is Fu Xi, I am 24 years old, and my in-game name is Thousand Blades. I am also the creator of the post 'Cultivation in the real world is possible' that has over a hundred million views now on the forums."

"Thank you for coming here on such short notice, Fu Xi. Can you tell us more about how you made that discovery? And what does it feel like to be a Cultivator? How is it any different from Cultivation Online?" The news anchor asked him.

Fu Xi nodded and said, "After playing Cultivation Online for a few days, I quickly became addicted to the world of cultivation, and I suddenly had a thought— what if I can become a Cultivator in the real world as well?"

"I knew it was ridiculous of me to have such thoughts. After all, there's no way something in a video game could possibly work in the real world as well. However, my curiosity would not calm down until I actually tried it. It

was at that point that I tried to cultivate in the real world using the cultivation technique I'd learned in Cultivation Online."

"Although it didn't work at first and I gave up for a few days, my instincts told me to try again, and so I did— until I managed to breakthrough and become a Cultivator."

"That's amazing," said the news anchor, and he continued, "If you don't mind, can you share with the audience the name of your cultivation technique and how you obtained it?"

Fu Xi nodded and said, "I don't mind. It's just an ordinary cultivation technique available to every disciple at the Nine Saber Mountain, and it's called Spirit Mountain Scripture."

"I know there are many people out there who do not believe in cultivation. Do you have any way to prove to them that it truly exists?"

"Well... I just became a Cultivator, so I cannot do anything crazy. However, my strength has increased tremendously since then. I can easily lift 100 pounds with a single hand despite my skinny physique."

"Indeed, you certainly don't look like you can lift even half of that much weight, much less all of it."

A few moments later, someone brought a 100-pound barbell onto the stage for Fu Xi.

After taking a deep breath, Fu Xi grabbed the center of the barbell with his stick-like arm and lifted it above his head with ease, shocking the news anchor and the audience.

"My god! What a performance! I thought you were joking!" The news anchor said, as he didn't believe for a second that Fu Xi would be able to lift something so heavy with his thin arms that clearly lacked the muscles.

"Well, this is the best I can do at my current level. Perhaps I will be able to use the other techniques from Cultivation Online if I increase my

cultivation." Fu Xi said with a proud look on his face.

Fu Xi and the news anchor continued to talk to each other about cultivation and whatnot.

Meanwhile, the other channels also had their own special guests, and all of them claim to have succeeded in cultivation.

"What do you think, brother? Do you think they're really Cultivators? Can we really cultivate in this world?" Yu Rou asked him through the phone.

"We can," Yuan answered quickly without hesitation, taking Yu Rou and Meixiu by surprise.

"Why do you sound so confident?" Yu Rou couldn't help but ask.

After a moment of silence, Yuan responded in a calm voice, "I am confident cultivation exists because... because I have also succeeded in becoming a Cultivator. In fact, I have been cultivating for a while now."

"Y-You what?" Yu Rou's dumbfounded voice resounded.

"Yuan..." Meixiu stared at him with her eyes wide with disbelief, almost as though she couldn't believe her ears.

Chapter 408 - Preparing For The Future

"I'm sorry for keeping this a secret until now, but I didn't want you to see me as someone crazy... And I was worried that all of this cultivation thing might only be inside my head— an illusion I made for myself." Yuan sighed.

"..."

After a moment of dead silence, Yu Rou asked him, "Brother, you're not crazy. How long have you been cultivating for?"

"It's been a while since I started so I cannot really remember, but I started cultivating even before I got kicked out of the Yu Family."

"How does it feel to become a Cultivator? Is it any different from Cultivation Online? And how long did it take you to succeed?" Yu Rou continued to ask him questions.

"Well... It definitely took me some time to become a Cultivator. When I first tried, I would feel pain all over my body, almost like I am being stabbed by needles. Eventually, I managed to breakthrough and become a Cultivator. As for how it feels... I can't really tell you since my body is in this state. However, I do feel very energetic, and having a breakthrough is very similar to what it would feel like inside Cultivation Online."

"That's it! I have made a decision! I am going to become a Cultivator in this world as well!" Yu Rou suddenly declared.

And she continued, "Can you imagine doing things in the real world that you could only do in Cultivation Online before? Like using martial techniques and having super strength? This is so exciting!"

However, Yuan said, "As exciting as it may seem, I am also very worried about the future. If everyone becomes a Cultivator, what's going to happen to our world? It might get chaotic."

"I don't think you have to worry too much, brother. Even if we can cultivate, I highly doubt we'll be able to do anything too crazy like flying and destroying mountains with a single fist. Although our world will definitely change, it probably won't be too drastic." Yu Rou said.

"I hope you're right..." Yuan said.

"By the way, what cultivation level are you right now, brother?" Yu Rou suddenly asked him.

"I honestly don't know, but if we use Cultivation Online for reference, I think I am a sixth-level Spirit Warrior," he said.

"S-Sixth level Spirit Warrior?!?!" Yu Rou exclaimed.

How is it possible that Yuan's cultivation in the real world is so high? He even surpasses the majority of players in Cultivation Online, much less the real world!

While most players are just entering the Spirit Warrior realm inside the game, Yuan was already a Spirit Warrior in the real world.

"A-Anyways, I will call you guys later. I have to prepare for school now. In fact, I am already running a little late because of the news. Bye!"

"Goodbye, Yu Rou."

After Yu Rou hung up, Meixiu suddenly spoke, "Yuan, is that why your body has been growing stronger and stronger despite not working out? Your body is unnaturally fit for someone who lies in bed all day."

"I think so," he said.

"..."

After a moment of silence, Meixiu asked, "If you continue to cultivate... do you think it could possibly help you move again?"

A smile appeared on Yuan's face after hearing her words, and he said, "I think so."

As much as he wanted to tell her that he was already recovering, he wanted to make sure that he could at least lift himself off the bed before he said anything, and at the rate he was recovering, he would probably need at least a couple more months before he could tell her about his recovery.

"What about you, Meixiu? Are you going to become a Cultivator too?"

"I don't know yet..." she mumbled.

"I think you should become a Cultivator, Meixiu." Yuan suddenly said.

And he continued, "Now that the entire world knows about cultivation in the real world, there will be many Cultivators in the near future, and when that happens, things might get chaotic. If I don't recover by then, I want you to be able to protect yourself at the very least."

"One thing I learned about Cultivators in Cultivation Online is that they can be unreasonable people."

Whether it's Cultivation Online or the real world, there will always be people who abuse their powers and use them to bully others.

After a moment of silence, Meixiu nodded her head and said, "I understand. I will become a Cultivator."

"Great! Once I am finished with the Dragon Temple, we can go look for a cultivation technique for you together! Of course, if you want, you can ask Feng Feng or Xiao Hua to see if they can help you find a cultivation technique since I still have 6 more days inside the Dragon Temple."

"It's okay. I will wait for you." Meixiu said.

Sometime later, after eating breakfast, Yuan returned to Cultivation Online whilst Meixiu went to research more about Cultivators online.

And as she'd expected, the world quickly learned that one could cultivate in the real world using cultivation techniques found inside Cultivation Online, and by the end of the day, nearly everybody in the world had heard about it.

Of course, there were countless questions that appeared because of this situation, such as how it was possible to use cultivation techniques from a video game and if cultivating in the real world was actually safe. However, no matter how suspicious people are or whether they believed it or not, it didn't stop people from trying to become Cultivators.

And as a result of this discovery, the playerbase for Cultivation Online skyrocketed, and powers around the world began preparing for the future—a future where Cultivators may rule the world.

By the end of the day, millions of people tried to cultivate with countless failures. With that being said, there were also plenty of people that had succeeded in their cultivation, and about one in every ten thousand people would become a Cultivator on their first day!

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Chapter 409 - The Great Ones Trial

Chapter 409 - The Great One's Trial

After returning to the Dragon Temple, Yuan flew into the air and looked at the formation around the city to see its progress, but as he'd expected, the formation remained unfinished.

"Since it's going to take a while for the formation to finish, I should use this time to look around the place and see if I can find the treasure room," Yuan mumbled to himself, and he proceeded to fly around the massive city that would've taken him months to explore if he had to do it on foot.

However, that was easier said than done. How was he supposed to find the treasure room in this massive and empty city? Where should he start?

After flying around the city for an hour, Yuan gave up and decided to start searching from the ground.

"Is there really nobody in this place besides myself?" Yuan mumbled to himself as he knocked on the closed doors.

"Hm? It's open?"

Realizing that the doors were not locked, Yuan decided to go inside.

"This is..."

Yuan was surprised to see furniture inside the buildings. In fact, every single building was fully organized with furniture, almost like people used to live in this place.

"Maybe people used to live in this place in the past..."

Sometime later, Yuan eventually stopped entering the buildings as there was nothing new after looking through over a hundred of them.

"What about the trials? Where can I do the trials?"

After pondering for some time, Yuan flew back into the air once again and activated his Dragon's Gaze, and instead of using it on the dragon statue, he scanned the city with it.

And to his surprise, he could see some of the buildings glowing a faint golden color, almost like they were surrounded by fireflies, and some buildings were glowing brighter than the others.

And just like how bright lights affected moths, Yuan went for the brightest building he saw.

A few minutes later, he knocked on the door just in case it was occupied.

When nobody answered, Yuan opened the door and entered the building.

The interior of the building looked almost the same as the other buildings, but there was an addition there— a small dragon statue placed directly in the center of the room.

Yuan ignored the other things in the room and approached the dragon statue.

The moment he got close enough to the statue, it suddenly began glowing, and the doors behind him closed.

Although he was startled, Yuan didn't panic or run away.

A few seconds later, the dark room began brightening despite the lack of light sources in the room.

Furthermore, the room also expanded, almost like the world itself was being stretched.

"Is this an illusion...?" Yuan wondered to himself.

The expansion of the room wouldn't stop until all of the furniture disappeared into the horizon.

Suddenly, a notification appeared before Yuan.

[The Great One's Trial has begun!]

[You have a new challenge!]

[Defeat as many enemies as you can within the time limit!]

[The more you defeat the stronger the enemies become and the better your rewards!]

[Difficulty has been adjusted based on your talents!]

Ding!

[3:59:59]

The moment the countdown started, Yuan could see human-like figures wearing armor that resembled the armor worn by the guards in the Ancient Dragon City appearing on the horizon, and there were tens if not hundreds of them appearing at once. Furthermore, they were all wielding different weapons.

Some of them had swords while others had spears. There were even some weapons that Yuan had never seen before.

Fortunately for him, they appeared pretty far in the distance, giving him some time to prepare.

"Their aura... First level Spirit Masters?" Yuan quickly retrieved his Empyrean Overlord and the Starry Abyss.

And not waiting for these armored figures to get close, Yuan used the Starry Abyss to attack them in the distance.

Boom!

The Starry Abyss easily tore holes in their bodies, and after killing 100 of them, the surviving armored figures' aura suddenly grew stronger, almost

like they'd leveled up or something, and they were now at the second level Spirit Master realm.

Yuan continued to slay these armored figures, and this challenge reminded him of the challenge on the 100th floor of the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower.

However, compared to the challenge on the 100th floor, there were not as many enemies, but they were certainly stronger— much stronger.

Second level... third level... fourth level...

The armored figures continued to grow stronger as Yuan destroyed them, and in just an hour, these armored figures entered the Spirit Grandmaster level.

[Heaven Splitting Sword Strike!]

Yuan unleashed a devastating attack that instantly destroyed over a hundred of these armored figures, increasing their strength once again to the second level Spirit Grandmaster.

Since this challenge required him to slay as many armored figures as he could in what little time he was given, Yuan spared no effort destroying as many of them as he could.

Yuan's spiritual energy depleted at an insane rate that would exhaust anyone with a similar cultivation base, but because of his skill Perfect Regeneration and the Nine Dragon Symbols inside his body, his body continuously absorbed the surrounding Qi as quickly as he used them, keeping Yuan from exhaustion.

Furthermore, once the armored figures had reached Spirit Grandmaster, fewer of them were being summoned, and their silver armor also changed to a golden color.

While Yuan continued his challenge inside Cultivation Online, the real world became rowdier and rowdier as more people woke up and learned

about cultivation.

"Sister Rou! Have you heard the news?! Apparently, cultivation is real and there are already Cultivators in our world!" Xiao Jingyi approached Yu Rou at school.

Yu Rou smiled and said, "Everybody and their mother have been talking about it since I woke up. How can I possibly not have heard about it by now?"

"What do you think about it? I am filled with excitement! In fact, I am going to start cultivating when I get home today! What about you? Are you going to cultivate?" Xia Jingyi said.

"I am also going to become a Cultivator." Yu Rou nodded.

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Chapter 410 - Golden Dragon Gift Box

Ding!

[You have completed the Great One's Trial!]

[Total kills: 7,945]

[Congratulations! You have set a new record!]

[You have been awarded a Golden Dragon Gift Box]

After the timer had reached zero, Yuan was given a golden box for his efforts.

"Haaa..."

Yuan laid on the floor in a tired manner as his surroundings returned to normal.

"The Great One said it'd be easy... What a joke! I nearly died fighting so many Spirit Grandmaster armored figures at once!" Yuan sighed out loud.

Fortunately for Yuan, the armored figures had their cultivation bases peaked at the 9th level Spirit Grandmaster or he would've been in real trouble.

Once he'd rested enough, Yuan opened the Golden Dragon Gift Box to see what was inside.

"This is... a necklace?"

Yuan retrieved a golden necklace from the Golden Dragon Gift Box.

[Refined Dragon Necklace]

[Grade: Divine]

[Quality: Peak]

[Mental Strength Required: 100,000]

[Soul Strength Required: 30,000]

[Description: A powerful necklace refined by the Great One. Deflects all spiritual techniques below Heaven-grade. Enhances the strength of one's own spiritual attacks by 50%.]

"Wow, this is quite a powerful treasure."

Yuan wore the treasure around his neck alongside the necklace Xiao Hua gave him, and he immediately felt safer.

"Wait... Spiritual attacks... Does the Dragon's Gaze count as a spiritual attack?" Yuan wondered to himself.

Sometime later, Yuan left the building to look at the formation around the city.

The moment he left the building, another notification appeared.

[1/3 Great One's Trials completed]

After taking a quick look at the formation to make sure it wasn't completed, Yuan went to look for another trial to do.

This time, he went for the building with the dimmest light.

[The Great One's Trial has begun!]

[You have a new challenge!]

[Withstand the pressure for three hours!]

[Difficulty has been adjusted based on your talents!]

Ding!

[2:59:59]

The moment the trial began, Yuan could feel an invisible pressure bearing down on him.

However, this pressure wasn't very strong in his opinion. In fact, he barely felt it.

After ten minutes, the pressure grew stronger, yet it still wasn't even for Yuan.

An hour later, the pressure was finally strong enough for Yuan to feel its effects, but it wasn't anything too strong, and he was still able to stand properly. It only felt like he was carrying a heavy backpack filled with rocks.

After another hour, the pressure was strong enough to make Yuan feel uncomfortable if he continued standing, so he took a seat on the cold floor.

The last hour was the most difficult. If it'd been another Cultivator, they would feel like they're being crushed by an entire mountain on her shoulders.

However, for Yuan, who was a Spirit Grandmaster, that mountain felt like a large boulder.

Of course, while boulders aren't anything to scoff at and could crush even a Spirit Warrior in an instant, Yuan was a Spirit Grandmaster. If he wanted to, he could carry even a couple of boulders and still be fine.

Three hours passed by in a flash, and at the end, Yuan received another Golden Dragon Gift Box.

Ding!

[You have completed the Great One's Trial!]

[Total time resisted: 3:00:00]

[Congratulations! You have set a new record!]

[You have been awarded a Golden Dragon Gift Box]

Yuan immediately opened the Golden Dragon Gift Box, but to his surprise, there was only an Earth-grade treasure inside.

[Dragon Needles]

[Grade: Earth]

[Quality: Peak]

[Description: Eight perfect needles crafted by the Great One. Usually used as a hidden weapon. Increases penetration by 100%]

"The trial was pretty easy compared to the last one so maybe that's why the reward is so bad," Yuan mumbled to himself.

Indeed, the trial he'd just beaten was one of the easiest trials in the Dragon Temple, hence the lack of reward.

With that being said, it was still an Earth-grade treasure, something most if not every single player besides Yuan would die for.

[2/3 Great One's Trials completed]

Sometime later, Yuan went back outside to look at the formation.

"Of course, it's still not finished. Guess I'll go ahead and finish my last trial now."

Yuan looked around the city with his Dragon's Gaze, looking specifically for the building that had the brightest glow.

After searching for a few minutes, Yuan flew to another building.

Although this building didn't glow as bright as his first one, it was definitely much brighter than his previous one.

Furthermore, this building appeared to be a restaurant of sorts.

After knocking on the door like usual, Yuan entered the building.

Sure enough, the interior looked like that of a restaurant with many tables and chairs.

Yuan took a deep breath before approaching the dragon statue in the middle.

Whoosh!

The world before him expanded once again until he had plenty of room.

[The Great One's Trial has begun!]

[You have a new challenge!]

[Dodge the incoming attacks for one hour or until you get hit 3 times!]

[Difficulty has been adjusted based on your talents!]

A timer suddenly appeared, but there were only three seconds on it.

[0:03]

[0:02]

[0:01]

Once the timer had reached zero, Yuan immediately sensed danger from behind him, and another timer appeared.

[0:59:50]

He quickly used his movement technique to leave his location, and the second he moved, a massive sword flew past where his neck had been just a second ago.

Three seconds after the first attack, Yuan could feel another sense of danger coming from his right side.

Whoosh!

An arrow suddenly appeared out of thin air a few meters away from his location and flew at his face.

The attacks continued to come from random locations, and the more Yuan dodged, the more threats would appear at once and the quicker they would appear.

Ten minutes into the challenge, Yuan was already being assaulted by 10 weapons at once, and they would attack him every two seconds.

Thirty minutes into the challenge, Yuan had to avoid over 50 threats at once, all of them coming at every single second, and things were just getting started.

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Chapter 411 - Duplicate Treasure

[0:00:02]

[0:00:01]

Ding!

[You have completed the Great One's Trial!]

[Total time dodged: 1:00:00]

[Total hits: 0]

[Congratulations! You have set a new record!]

[You have been awarded a Golden Dragon Gift Box]

Yuan collapsed on the floor after he saw the notification.

"If I didn't level up the movement technique at the Ancient Dragon City, I might not have been able to pass this trial without getting hit a few times..." Yuan sighed in an exhausted manner.

Towards the end, he had to dodge over a hundred attacks from every direction, and the attacks would come at every second, leaving him almost no room to breathe.

Fortunately for him, the movement technique he'd learned from Feng Yuxiang was truly as powerful as she had claimed.

A few moments later, once the world returned to normal and he had rested enough, Yuan opened the Golden Dragon Gift Box to see what was inside.

[You have obtained 'Dragon Temple Treasure Key']

"Wait a minute..." Yuan was dumbfounded when he saw the notification.

"I already have the Dragon Temple Treasure Key!" Yuan exclaimed.

He remembers obtaining the same thing at the Carp Leaping Over Dragon's Gate Tower after reaching the 100th floor! What is he going to do with this extra key? Will it be a useless treasure?

Normally, one wouldn't be able to obtain the Dragon Temple Treasury Key unless they got lucky with one of the trials in the Dragon Temple, yet Yuan somehow managed to obtain it before even entering the place.

"I did all of that just for a duplicate treasure... What luck..." Yuan shook his head.

[3/3 Great One's Trials completed]

[You have reached the limit of trials you can complete!]

[You may continue to do the trials, but you will not receive any reward!]

"To add insult to injury, that was my last attempt... Ah, whatever." Yuan gave up, as there was nothing he could do at this point.

Sometime later, Yuan returned to the dragon statue and looked at the progress of the formation.

"Still not done, huh?"

He decided to log off for the day shortly after.

"How's everything going, Meixiu?" Yuan asked her during dinner.

"Well... As you can expect, the entire world is in an uproar right now," she said.

"I'm not surprised."

"The prices for cultivation techniques have also skyrocketed since then. Even a Mortal-grade cultivation technique could go for tens of thousands of dollars," she added.

"Also not surprising..."

"Governments around the world want to regulate cultivation, but with so many people doing it in secrecy, it's near impossible to do anything about it."

"I see..."

After a moment of silence, Yuan said, "Oh, yeah. You should have the Basic Qi Gathering Technique, right? It was given to everyone when we started the game. You should try to get a feel for cultivation in Cultivation Online before you attempt it in the real world. It's going to be like practice until you get a better cultivation technique."

"Okay, I will try it later. What about you? Will you be playing tonight?"

"Yes, I am waiting for some massive formation to finish, but it's taking forever. Though, I don't want to miss it when it does finish."

Sometime later, Yuan returned to the game and continued to wait for the formation to finish.

Meixiu went to clean the dishes before entering the game.

Meanwhile, after school, Yu Rou was summoned by her parents.

Once she arrived at their main house, Yu Rou immediately noticed the empty boxes laid outside the door, causing her to raise her eyebrows.

A few minutes later, she went to look for her parents in their bedroom, which was an odd place for a meeting.

When she entered their room, the first thing she noticed was the familiar-looking console on their bed.

"You're finally here, huh?" Yu Yong said to her from the bed.

"As you can see, we'll be playing Cultivation Online as well."

"Eh...?" Yu Rou stared at them with a dumbfounded look on her face.

"I'm sure you've heard by now, but apparently one can become a Cultivator if they play this game and use their cultivation techniques." Tang Lee said.

And she continued, "Yu Rou, since you have been playing this game for some time now, you should have enough experience as a Cultivator inside the game. The other families have already started cultivating, and some of their children have even succeeded in cultivating. Therefore, you're going to become a Cultivator as well."

"I-I understand..." Yu Rou mumbled in a dazed voice.

Although she was already planning on becoming a Cultivator, it was still shocking to hear it from her parents' mouths.

"If becoming a Cultivator truly increases one's longevity and grants them superhuman strength like they say, that's not something we can ignore." Yu Yong said.

Sometime later, Yu Rou returned to her own house.

After eating dinner and taking a quick shower, Yu Rou sat on her bed in the lotus position and tried to cultivate using the cultivation technique she has been using in Cultivation Online.

Her breathing quickly calmed and became rhythmic, and her mind was cleared of all thoughts except the cultivation technique.

Yu Rou eventually entered this mythical state that was similar to enlightenment yet it was not true enlightenment.

A few hours later, Yu Rou suddenly felt a nostalgic feeling spread throughout her body.

"Did I succeed? Am I a Cultivator now? That was easier than I'd expected..." Yu Rou opened her eyes and stood up, feeling energetic all over her body.

She then turned to look at her desk.

After pondering for a moment, she approached it and tried to lift it with one hand.

Yu Rou didn't expect anything at first, but to her surprise, she'd managed to lift the whole desk with a single arm! And with relative ease too!

"H-Heavens! It's real! I am really a Cultivator!" Yu Rou exclaimed in an excited voice.

Yu Rou immediately went to pick up the phone and tried to contact Meixiu, but when nobody picked up, she called Xia Jingyi instead.

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Chapter 412 - Closing School Early

"Jingyi, how's your cultivation going? Have you become a Cultivator yet?"

"By the sound of your voice, I can tell that you've already become a Cultivator. Congratulations, Sister Rou. Unfortunately, I am still trying to breakthrough." Xia Jingyi's voice resounded from the phone.

"Don't worry, I'm sure you'll breakthrough soon."

"What about you? Has anything changed now that you're a Cultivator? Have you gotten stronger like they say you would?" Xia Jingyi asked.

"Yes! You won't believe this, but I could lift my desk with a single arm! It was really surprising!" Yu Rou said.

"That crazy?! I'm going to continue my cultivation now! Even if I have to skip tonight's sleep, I am going to do it!" Xia Jingyi said.

"Me, too! I may already be a Cultivator but I still want to continue improving! I'll see you tomorrow at school!" Yu Rou said her goodbyes before closing the phone.

And for the rest of the night, Yu Rou would sit on her bed in the lotus position, slowly improving her cultivation.

The following morning, despite missing a night of sleep, Yu Rou felt incredibly refreshed and full of energy.

"Unlike Cultivation Online, cultivation is much slower in the real world, which isn't really that surprising. And with a lack of treasures to assist us, we'll be even slower." Yu Rou mumbled.

Cultivation Online was filled with rich resources that could help boost one's cultivation within seconds, but in the real world, no such resources exist and Cultivators must rely on their own talents and patience to improve their cultivation.

"I guess this is also good. It would be bad if people can simply buy their cultivation levels like they do in Cultivation Online, becoming Spirit Warriors in just a few weeks." Yu Rou mumbled.

In Cultivation Online, there are plenty of rich people who would buy treasures using real money to boost their cultivation base, bypassing the earlier levels. Of course, the higher their cultivation, the more expensive each level got.

Once one reaches Spirit Warrior, the amount one would need to spend to increase a level was so high that only the richest people in the world would dare to spend that much.

Now that one cannot simply buy their way to the top, everyone— regardless of their status or wealth— will have a chance to become a top Cultivator in the real world!

"Meanwhile, Brother is already nearing Spirit Master... If he could move his body, how powerful would he be in this world?" Yu Rou wondered to herself as she prepared for school.

Sometime later, Yu Rou arrived at school, and to her surprise, the place looked even more empty than usual.

"Where is everybody?" Xia Jingyi asked the teacher.

The teacher showed a bittersweet smile and said, "Because of the cultivation craze, everybody is staying home to cultivate."

Yu Rou and the other few students in the classroom were left dumbfounded by the teacher's words.

Everybody was skipping school to cultivate? As crazy as that sounded, it wasn't that surprising!

"It's not just the students." The teacher continued.

"A couple of the teachers here have also resigned this morning, so we're also understaffed at this moment."

"What's going to happen to our classes now?" Yu Rou then asked.

"The principal has issued a gathering later today, so we'll probably know about it at that time. In the meantime, you can do whatever."

The students looked at each other silently.

Sometime later, the students there gathered in a circle and began talking to each other about cultivation.

"Have any of you tried cultivating now?"

"I have, but I couldn't make any breakthroughs."

"Me too. It feels like there's something blocking me and I cannot move forward."

"I have that feeling as well!"

"I actually managed to have a breakthrough this morning right before school." Xia Jingyi said with a smile on her face.

"Whoa! So you're a Cultivator now, right?! Show us what you can do!" The other students immediately looked at her with admiration.

"Haha... compared to Sister Rou, I am nothing. She became a Cultivator last night." Xia Jingyi said.

"As expected of Miss Yu! You're not only talented in music but even in cultivation!"

Yu Rou showed a stiff smile.

If only they knew what her brother was capable of.

A few moments later, Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi showed off to the other students their new profound strength by lifting desks and chairs and treating them as though they're weightless.

"My god! I have been skeptical this entire time, but after seeing it with my own eyes, I cannot do anything but believe it!"

About an hour later, Yu Rou and the others in her class went to the auditorium where the principal, teachers, and other students in the school were gathered.

"Ahem. Thank you for coming here. As most of you, if not all of you already know by now, we're missing more than just a few students, and this is all because of the cultivation craze since yesterday. After speaking with your parents, we have agreed to close the school even earlier than anticipated."

Although the place was dead silent, all of the students were filled with excitement and had an urge to start screaming.

The principal continued, "While I don't know when we'll reopen, it probably won't be anytime soon, and depending on how this cultivation thing changes our world, we might never open again."

"I apologize for any inconvenience this may have caused you, and if you plan on becoming a Cultivator, I wish you the best of luck. Do any of you have questions? This is your last chance to ask them."

After spending a couple of minutes answering the students' and teachers' questions, the principal dismissed everyone.

"What are you going to do now, Sister Rou?" Xia Jingyi asked her once they left the school.

"I am going to focus on improving my cultivation," she said.

"What about Cultivation Online? Are you going to continue playing?"

"Of course!" Yu Rou quickly responded.

And she continued, "I will play Cultivation Online in the morning and cultivate at night. A perfect balance if I say so myself."

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Chapter 413 - Spirit Severing Physique

After breakfast, Meixiu laid on her bed and returned to Cultivation Online.

Once she was in the game, she took a seat on the cold floor in the lotus position and tried to cultivate using the Basic Qi Gathering Technique she'd obtained at the beginning of the game.

When Feng Yuxiang and the others noticed this, they turned to look at her with raised eyebrows.

"Are you trying to cultivate? I thought you didn't have any cultivation techniques." Feng Yuxiang couldn't help but ask her out of curiosity.

Meixiu nodded and said, "I have this technique called Basic Qi Gathering Technique. I want to get used to cultivation before I do it for real."

"What? Basic Qi Gathering Technique? That trash everybody uses?" Feng Yuxiang immediately expressed disgust on her face.

"Meixiu, I suggest you don't use that trash cultivation technique and wait until you have something better even if it's only for practice. After all, the better your cultivation technique, the stronger your foundations will be." Feng Yuxiang said.

And she continued, "If you use that cultivation technique to form your foundations, it might affect your future by limiting it."

"For example, if two people start cultivating with different techniques—one with an inferior technique and the other with a superior technique—even if the Cultivator with the inferior technique changes his cultivation

technique for a better one in the future, his cultivation would not go as far as the person who has been using a superior cultivation technique since the beginning unless that person cripples his cultivation base and starts all over again."

"This is why most Cultivators stay with one cultivation technique for their entire life even if they find something slightly better, as it's not worth the hassle of restarting your cultivation technique from the beginning."

"I see..." Meixiu stopped trying to cultivate after hearing Feng Yuxiang's words.

"I mean, if you really want to cultivate, I guess it's okay for you since you won't really lose much even if you have to start again. However, it's a painful process to restart your cultivation base without damaging your Dantian, and a single mistake will cripple you for the rest of your life." Feng Yuxiang added.

"It's okay. I will wait until I have a better cultivation technique." Meixiu said.

"I would give you a cultivation technique if I had one, but as a Divine Beast, we don't really rely on cultivation techniques to cultivate, and we absorb Spirit Qi as naturally as breathing. Though, having a cultivation technique would definitely help us cultivate faster."

"Xiao Hua also only has one cultivation technique, but you're not compatible with it."

"What about you, Lan Yingying? You got something that could help her out?" Feng Yuxiang turned to ask her.

Lan Yingying shook her head and said, "Unfortunately, I don't have any techniques. I cultivate by consuming other magical beasts."

"What a unique physique... It's somewhat similar to the Young Master, but he eats their cores instead. Hmm? Speaking of physique, do you have any unique physiques, Meixiu?" Feng Yuxiang asked her.

Meixiu nodded and said, "It's a physique called Spirit Severing Physique."

"S-Spirit Severing Physique?! A Divine-grade physique?!" Feng Yuxiang exclaimed.

Meixiu nodded, and she asked, "Do you know what it does?"

"The Spirit Severing Physique is a rare and powerful physique that allows you to separate your spirit from your body! It's kind of like Divine Sense, and you're near invincible as long as you're in the state!" Feng Yuxiang said.

"Furthermore, while you're in that state, you can bypass all sorts of formations and defenses that would normally block people from entering. It's a highly coveted physique since you can enter places where people normally cannot and not have to worry about traps."

"Even in the upper heavens, your talents will be useful. In fact, your talents will probably become more valuable as you ascend because things get increasingly more dangerous the higher you go."

"I know some people who have the same physique, and they would sell their services by scouting Legacy Tombs and other dangerous places for information in exchange for an enormous amount of wealth and resources."

"I see..." Meixiu nodded, understanding her physique a little bit more now.

"How do I do it? I would like to try," she then said.

"Hmm..." Feng Yuxiang pondered for a moment and said, "Unfortunately, I don't think your body can handle it right now, especially since you're still a mortal. Once you reach Spirit Warrior, you'll probably be able to do it, and as you grow stronger, you'll be able to enter your spirit form for much longer, and you can even travel further away from your real body."

"Okay," Meixiu said.

Meanwhile, inside the Dragon Temple, Yuan flew around the city with his Dragon's Gaze activated the entire time.

"I have flown around the city a couple of times now, but I still cannot find the treasure room..." Yuan sighed.

Where could the treasure room be hiding? He even checked all of the buildings that were glowing just in case.

It was at this moment the city suddenly began rumbling again.

"What's happening? Could it be the formation?" Yuan quickly returned to the dragon statue.

Once he was at the dragon statue, Yuan looked at the formation that looked completed.

"It looks completed, but where is the legacy?"

Just as Yuan thought this, the dragon statue behind him suddenly began moving.

Whoosh!

The dragon statue slowly transformed, turning from metal to a more realistic material, and it was even growing bigger. In just moments, the dragon statue went from looking like a statue to a real dragon, and it even flew into the sky and circled around the city exactly nine times before approaching Yuan.

"Are you the one who seeks my legacy?" The dragon statue spoke to Yuan as though it was their first encounter.

Yuan, who was still hovering in the air, nodded his head.

"You're the Great One, right? I am interested in your legacy. Can you tell me more about it?"

Author's Note: I have decided to start a new novel with an antihero protagonist as an experiment. Check out 'Hero's Carnage' if you're interested.

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Chapter 414 - The Great Ones Legacy

Chapter 414 - The Great One's Legacy

"Interested?" The Great One's statue raised its eyebrows at Yuan's words.

"You're merely interested in my Legacy? You know, even Immortals and Gods covet my Legacy." The Great One's statue said to him.

"Yes, but it sounds like a lot of responsibility," Yuan said.

"Responsibility? Hahaha! Of course, it's a lot of responsibility! Not anyone can just obtain the Great One's Legacy!"

"What is the Great One's Legacy, anyway? According to my knowledge, I only have to ascend to the upper heavens and find the real Great One, right?"

"That's the gist of it, yes. However, there are more things you should keep in mind."

The Great One's eyes suddenly flickered with a profound light, and it continued, "First and foremost, once you obtain the Legacy, you will have exactly 100 years to find the real Great One who is always wandering the Nine Heavens."

"100 years? That's a long time..." Yuan mumbled.

The Great One's statue raised its eyebrows. 100 years is a long time? In its eyes, 100 years could disappear in the blink of an eye, especially for most Immortals that can live for millions of years with ease.

"Next, you are only allowed to hold the Great One's Legacy once in your lifetime, so if you happen to run into another chance to obtain the Great One's Legacy, just know that you won't be able to accept it."

"There will be other chances to obtain this Legacy?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"Yes. The Great One has multiple trials spread across the Nine Heavens so everyone has a chance to obtain his Legacy."

"Does this mean there can be more than one person carrying the Great One's Legacy at one time?" Yuan asked.

The statue nodded and said, "There are currently 99 people who are carrying the Great One's Legacy as of this moment. If you accept it, you will be the 100th person. However, nobody has been able to complete the Legacy— not even the people at the upper heavens."

"Can there only be one person who completes the Legacy?" Yuan then asked.

"No, there can be multiple people. However, the earlier you complete it, the better your rewards."

"I see..."

"Anyways, as for the last thing you should know about the Great One's Legacy... There's actually a curse within it that will make your cultivation life harder if you accept it."

"Huh? A curse?" Yuan raised his eyebrows again.

"It's nothing malicious, but if you accept it, you might lose some of your luck, and there may be unfortunate encounters that you would otherwise not experience if you weren't carrying the Great One's Legacy. Basically, it will make things more difficult for you. If you can overcome the curse and find the Great One while carrying this Legacy, you will be awarded immense wealth that would make even Immortals and Gods jealous."

"Do you accept this Legacy?" The statue asked him.

Ding!

[You have been offered to carry the Great One's Legacy!]

[Do you accept?]

Yuan didn't immediately answer, and after pondering for a few moments, he said, "I have a question before I decide."

"..."

The statue was speechless. If it was anybody else, they would've long accepted the Legacy.

"If I accept the Great One's Legacy, can I accept another Legacy in the future if I have the chance?" Yuan asked.

"You... You're a greedy one." The statue responded in a dumbfounded voice.

After a moment of silence, the statue continued to speak, "There is no limit on how many Legacy one can carry at a time. However, don't bite more than you can chew."

Yuan nodded, "Since that's the case, I will accept the Great One's Legacy."

"Good!"

The statue's eyes suddenly glowed brightly before shooting a golden beam of light inside Yuan's body.

Ding!

[You have accepted the Great One's Legacy!]

[You have 100 years to find the Great One!]

[Because of the Great One's Legacy, you have been cursed with 'Minor Misfortune'!]

[Minor Misfortune]

[Curse Grade: Heaven]

[Description: A curse that lowers your Luck by 500]

"You now carry the Great One's Legacy— carry it with pride and honor. Good luck." The statue said to him.

"Oh! Before you go, can you tell me where the treasure room is? I looked everywhere but still couldn't find it... Even a little hint is good enough." Yuan suddenly said to it.

The statue didn't say anything, but its gaze turned to look in a certain direction for a good moment before it flew around the city nine times before returning to its original place and turning back into a metal statue.

"Thank you." Yuan bowed to the statue before flying towards the direction it had hinted.

Sometime later, Yuan reached the end of the city, yet he still couldn't find the treasure room.

He then decided to fly back and forth this same path a few more times just in case he missed something, but alas, the treasure room still remained nowhere to be seen.

Yuan decided to stop and ponder for some time.

A few minutes later, he turned to look at the area outside the city, which was only a desolate land that had no signs of life.

"Maybe the treasure room is outside the city and somewhere in this desolate land?" Yuan mumbled to himself.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan decided to leave the city and enter the desolate land.

The moment Yuan left the city, he could feel an ominous feeling looming around him, almost like there were people looking at him from every direction.

Furthermore, the spiritual energy was completely different compared to inside the city— it was more chaotic and impure.

'I sure hope this is the right way and the statue wasn't just playing with me...' Yuan swallowed nervously.

After flying straight for an hour, Yuan suddenly felt a chill down his spine, causing him to turn around.

When he turned around, he was greeted by a massive shadowy figure that resembled a dragon following a few miles behind him. However, because of its massive and long size, it looked like it was right behind him.

"W-What the heck is that?!" Yuan felt his heart skip a beat after seeing this unknown entity suddenly behind him.

Author's Note: I have decided to start a new novel with an antihero protagonist as an experiment. Check out 'Hero's Carnage' if you're interested.

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Chapter 415 - Shadow Realm

"Human... human... human..." The shadowy entity following behind Yuan mumbled in a ghastly voice.

Yuan's body shuddered even more after hearing this unknown entity's voice, and its glowing red eyes that emitted bloodlust didn't help either.

"What are you?! And what do you want from me?!" Yuan shouted at it while he increased his flying speed.

However, the dark entity ignored his questions and merely continued to mumble in a ghastly voice that was devoid of all emotions, "Human... human... human..."

When it noticed Yuan increasing his speed, the unknown entity also increased its speed.

After being chased for a few minutes, Yuan could see small glowing red dots around him in the distance.

"Oh, the Great One! I really hope you're not messing with me now and that the treasure room is really this way!" Yuan cried out loud as he increased his flying speed even more.

"Human... human..."

"Human...!"

"Human... human...!"

More and more shadowy figures began emerging from the darkness, and in just half an hour, there were over a dozen shadowy entities following Yuan.

Seeing this, Yuan decided to attack these entities with the Starry Abyss, but the dagger went straight through these entities' bodies.

"HUMAN!"

The dark entities suddenly screamed, causing Yuan to tremble from fright.

'I probably shouldn't have done that!' He cried inwardly after seeing the aftermath.

Not only have the dark entities sped up, but they were even beginning to attack him by spitting out these black balls that would explode after a short time!

"Whoa!"

Yuan quickly dodged these ominous-looking balls.

One of these dark balls touched the ground, and when that happened, the ground immediately disappeared the next second!

"What are these things?!" Yuan cried out loud as he sped up even more.

After flying for a few minutes while constantly dodging these shadow balls, Yuan suddenly felt a sense of danger from below, causing him to look down at the ground, and that's when he noticed the sea of shadowy hands that had sprouted from the ground out of nowhere.

These shadowy hands danced left and right, and some of them would suddenly extend and shoot straight at Yuan like a spear.

Yuan's forehead was covered in sweat at this moment. This has to be one of the most ridiculous situations he has experienced in Cultivation Online thus far.

Furthermore, the uncertainty of the situation and these unknown entities only made things worse.

"What are you doing here, human?"

A gentle voice that was the complete opposite of the ghastly voices Yuan had gotten used to by now suddenly resounded, taking Yuan by surprise.

Compared to the ghastly voices that sounded like he was being haunted, this gentle voice sounded like it came from a goddess.

Another shadowy figure appeared a few meters in front of Yuan, but it didn't take a monstrous shape like the others. Instead, it had a feminine figure— and quite the mature one at that.

Yuan subconsciously stopped moving when his path was blocked by this shadowy figure.

The shadowy figure suddenly lifted her hand and made a beckoning gesture with her hand, forcing him to fly towards her.

However, the shadowy figure also moved back as Yuan approached her.

"Continue moving. If you're caught by those things, you'll turn into one of them and be trapped in here forever. Don't mind me." The gentle voice spoke to him.

Yuan nodded and continued to fly towards the shadowy figure.

"So? What is a human like you doing here in the Shadow Realm?" The gentle voice asked him again.

"Shadow Realm? What is this place? And what are these things behind me?"

"The Shadow Realm is a forbidden land where banished souls like them— like us dwell for eternity. It's rare for living beings to appear here," she responded.

"I see... Well, I am trying to head to the treasure room... And the Great One suggested I go this way... Hopefully, I didn't go too far..." Yuan spoke to the shadowy figure while he dodged the incoming attacks from all sides.

"The Dragon Treasury? You're definitely going the right way. However, you might have to fly for a few more hours before you reach it." The shadowy figure said to him.

"I-I have to continue this for a few hours?!" Yuan felt an urge to cry.

The treasure room better be worth all this effort.

"Since we have plenty of time to spare, why don't we talk a little more? It's been forever since I have spoken with a living being." The shadowy figure suddenly said.

"I would love to chat with you, but as you can see... it's not easy to talk while trying to avoid these things behind me." Yuan said.

"Hmm..."

The shadowy figure seemed to be pondering about something.

After a moment of silence, she spoke again, "Although this is going to be problematic for me later, I guess it's worth it if I can speak with you."

The shadowy figure suddenly snapped her fingers, causing a profound black ripple to appear around her.

This black ripple instantly swept the place, and when it touched the shadowy entities following behind Yuan, it caused them to shiver before turning tails and flying the other direction.

"T-Thank you..." Yuan said to the shadowy figure after taking a deep breath.

"That will only stop the weaker ones from chasing after you. There are stronger entities in here that even I cannot control," said the shadowy figure.

And she continued, "Anyways, now that they're not bothering you, let's talk."

"What do you want to talk about?"

"How long has it been since the Primordial Era? What kind of era are we in right now?"

"Primordial Era? Sorry, I don't know..."

"That's fine. Then do you know who's the current ruler of the Nine Heavens?"

Yuan shook his head. "I don't know much about the Nine Heavens since I arrived in this world recently."

"Oh? Tell me more." The shadowy figure said, her interest piqued.

"Well... I am from a world called 'Earth', and I have come to the Nine Heavens to explore it... I guess..." Yuan said.

"Earth? I have never heard of this place before. It must be some kind of minor world outside the Nine Heavens." The shadowy figure said.

Author's Note: I have decided to start a new novel with an antihero protagonist as an experiment. Check out 'Hero's Carnage' if you're interested.

Chapter 416 - Banished Souls

"If you don't mind me asking, just what are you guys? Banished souls? Does this mean you're dead?" Yuan suddenly asked the shadowy figure.

"Dead, huh? While we're not truly dead, we might as well be considered dead since we cannot leave this place," she said.

"We're souls— evil spirits so to speak, and our physical bodies have long rotted from this world."

"Why? Why were you guys banished here? Did you do something wrong?"

The shadowy figure giggled in a graceful tone before speaking, "Maybe. Some considered us as sinners while others considered us as heroes— it all depends on which side you stand."

And she continued, "As for what we did... Well, we waged war against heaven and the ruler of the Nine Heavens— the Celestial Emperor. And as you can probably tell from our current situation, we lost the war and were banished to this Shadow Realm."

"The Celestial Emperor? Why would you do something like that?" Yuan couldn't understand their motivation at all.

The shadowy figure immediately sneered in a cold voice, "That bastard is nothing more than a tyrant who abused his power by controlling the resources in the Nine Heavens. A Cultivator should not have to get on their knees and kiss the Celestial Emperor's feet to obtain resources, yet that's what we had to do! If we don't become his dogs, we would be denied the good resources and could only cultivate the low-tier resources!"

"Imagine being told you cannot drink water no matter if it's water from a natural spring or a store, and you're forced to drink the dirty water on the streets unless you decide to give up your dignity and become the Celestial Emperor's lapdog! This is why we waged war against that bastard! But alas, he had too much power and influence. It was a one-sided slaughter."

"However, it would still require a lot of effort and resources to kill all of us, so they decided to banish our spirits into this place."

"I don't know how long it has been since the war, but the majority of souls in this place have long lost their minds and gone crazy. They're now just mindless spirits wandering the Shadow Realm with an insatiable bloodlust."

"How come you seem to be fine?" Yuan couldn't help but ask her, who seemed perfectly sane and was even talking to him calmly.

"Do I seem fine? It might not seem like it, but I am actually trying my best to not consume you even now."

"Eh?" Yuan immediately stopped moving when he heard her words, and he stared at her figure with a dumbfounded look on his face.

"Hahaha!"

The shadowy figure suddenly burst out laughing after she saw Yuan's reaction.

"I'm just joking! You should've seen your face just now!"

"R-Really?" Yuan became even more dumbfounded.

"Although most of the spirits in this place have long lost their mind, there are still some who are completely rational and sane, and they all used to be incredibly powerful Immortals. Of course, I am one of these individuals." The shadowy figure pointed at herself.

Although she didn't have any facial features on her face besides two glowing red eyes, Yuan could somehow see a prideful expression on her face right now.

"Do you know why?" She suddenly asked.

"No... Why?"

"Because I have hope that I will be able to leave this place one day," she said, taking him by surprise.

"Eh? I thought you were trapped here for eternity? And how can you leave without a body?"

"Having a physical body is the least of my worries. As an Immortal, even if my physical body is destroyed, I won't die as long as my soul remains unharmed. Also, I can recreate my body if I have enough resources. The only problem is leaving the Shadow Realm. I cannot do it by myself."

The shadowy figure then pointed at him.

"This is where you come into play. I want you to help me by bringing me out of this place," she said in a solemn voice.

"Of course, I won't ask you to do it for free. The fact you're in this place means you're special, and judging by your cultivation and young appearances, you're also very talented. Whether it be cultivation techniques or treasures, I'm pretty sure you already have it all. Therefore, I will give you something more valuable than any treasure or technique there is in this world."

The shadowy figure then turned her finger, pointing at herself.

"Me. I will give myself to you."

"Eh?" Yuan stared at her with wide eyes.

"If you help me leave this place, once I recreate my body, I will give my everything to you— my body, my heart, and even my soul."

Before Yuan could even respond, she continued to speak, "I will have you know that I used to be one of three Ethereal Immortal Fairies, a title that's exclusive to the most beautiful and powerful women in all Nine Heavens.

Even the Celestial Emperor coveted me— to the point where he was willing to forgive me for attacking him if I gave myself to him."

"I... I don't know what to say..." Yuan said in a dazed voice, as this was too sudden.

"Even if I want to help you, I don't know how to..."

"It's okay if you don't know. I will give you the instructions," she said.

"I—"

However, before Yuan could even respond, another voice suddenly resounded.

"Don't be fooled by that sly vixen, young man. Everything that comes out of her mouth is nothing but fart— only to seduce naive young men like you so that you would do all of her biddings."

Midway through the sentence, another shadowy figure appeared in their location, and this figure had the shape of a tall and muscular man.

"W-Who are you?" Yuan asked.

"I used to be the Sect Master of the Immortal Monastery, one of the top sects in all of Nine Heavens during the Primordial Era. If you help me leave this place, I will grant you any wish that you may have. Power, status, wealth, women— anything at all."

Author's Note: Check out my antihero novel 'Hero's Carnage'.

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Chapter 417 - Banished Immortals

Yuan was speechless after this newcomer's arrival.

"Now hold on just a damn minute! Who are you calling a sly vixen? How dare you tarnish my reputation with such an outrageous lie!" The Immortal Fairy said in an angry voice.

She then turned to look at Yuan and continued, "Don't listen to him, young man. Everything I said is the truth. As much as I want to get out of this place, I won't lower myself to such a standard to do so, unlike someone over here."

"Young man, that vixen is known for seducing young men and tossing them aside like trash once she's done with them. I cannot count how many young men she had ruined in the past," said the Sect Master.

And he continued, "Vixen, why don't you tell him your other title besides the Ethereal Immortal Fairy? Or are you scared that it might reveal your true self? Here, let me help you then! Besides Ethereal Immortal Fairy, you're also known as the Deceitful Blood Empress!"

"Wha—?! That stupid title was given to me by those losers I'd rejected! That has nothing to do with me being deceitful!" The Immortal Fairy refuted.

And she continued to defend herself, "As one of the top beauties in the Nine Heavens, it's only natural that I would have countless admirers! However, whenever I would reject someone, they would spread lies to get back at me! Young man, you have to believe me! I am innocent!"

"This man, on the other hand, is known for manipulating people! People also called him Devil Hand Madman back in the Primordial Era! If it's

anyone you should be careful about, it's him!"

The Immortal Fairy and the Sect Master began pointing fingers at each other. It was a weird sight to witness for Yuan.

"Umm..." Yuan suddenly interrupted them and asked, "What do you guys plan on doing if you do leave this place? Continue fighting the Celestial Emperor?"

The two of them stopped fighting each other and turned to look at Yuan in silence.

After a moment of silence, they laughed, "Hahaha! Of course, not! We have already lost the war— there's no point in fighting anymore. Furthermore, what can one or two of us do against the Celestial Emperor when an entire army has failed to defeat him? We also don't know what it's like outside, too."

The Sect Master then said, "My plans will mostly depend on what is happening outside and the current situation with the Celestial Emperor. If he's still ruling the Nine Heavens, then I will probably remain lowkey and change my identity. If that bastard is dead, then I will restore my sect and its glory."

"Hmph. Unlike him, I don't have such big ambitions. I am simply so bored of this place that I don't care what I do outside as long as I'm not stuck in this dump." The Immortal Fairy said.

"Hmm..." Yuan was relieved to hear that they didn't want revenge or anything too crazy, as he pitied their situation and wanted to help them.

While they could also be tricking him, he didn't sense any malice coming from them.

"Then can you tell me how I can help you leave this place? I hope you're not going to say something like 'I will need to borrow your body'..." Yuan said to them.

"Hahaha... Borrow your body? We're not ghosts. Although it's possible, it's not very practical, and it's not very convenient for us either." The Immortal Fairy laughed.

"Then how?"

"It's really simple, actually." The Sect Master said, and he continued, "One of us will occupy your treasure until we can recreate our body."

Yuan pondered for a moment and said, "Since it's that easy, why are you guys fighting over who I should help, even trying to bash the other person?"

"Well... Because even though it may sound simple, it actually requires a lot of your soul strength to keep us safe inside the treasure, and it's not possible for someone at your level to help two of us at once. However, the biggest issue is that the treasure we can occupy is limited to Soul Weapons, and people normally can only wield one at a time." The Sect Master said.

"You have a Soul Weapon, right? I saw you use it, hence why I even asked you to help me." The Immortal Fairy said.

"Well... I do have a Soul Weapon... In fact, I have two, so I might be able to help both of you." Yuan said.

"What?! You have two Soul Weapons?!"

They both exclaimed in a surprised voice.

Even during the Primordial Era that gave birth to the most talented geniuses the Nine Heavens has seen to date, it was incredibly rare for someone to wield two Soul Weapons at once.

"Haha! This is great! This means both of us can leave!" The Sect Master shouted in a blissful voice.

"If he has enough soul strength to wield two Soul Weapons, he'll most likely have enough soul strength to help both of us. However, his cultivation is still lacking severely." The Immortal Fairy said.

And she continued, "You must be at least a Spirit Emperor before you can help us."

"Spirit Emperor? That'll take years! And I only have a couple more days in this place before I have to leave!" Yuan said to them.

"It's only a few years. We have been here for countless years. A few more years won't make any difference to us. And you can simply come back to this place in the future." The Immortal Fairy said.

"I'm not sure I will be able to return to this place after I leave, though..."

"Don't worry, the Shadow Realm exists in many places. As long as you continue to explore the Nine Heavens, you'll eventually come back here again. Hopefully, you'll be a Spirit Emperor by then," said the Sect Master.

"So? Will you be willing to help us? We'll definitely repay this debt and more in the future." The Immortal Fairy asked him again.

Ding!

[You have received a Hidden Quest!]

[Hidden Quest: Banished Immortals]

[Difficulty: Impossible]

[Description: Help the two banished souls escape from the Shadow Realm]

[Reward: ???]

Chapter 418 - Entering The Treasure Room

'Impossible? Just how difficult is this hidden quest?' Yuan was surprised by the difficulty of the quest.

'Maybe the reason it says impossible is because it's literally impossible for me right now, as I don't have the required cultivation to help them.' Yuan wondered if this was the case.

After a moment of silence, Yuan looked at the two shadowy figures and said, "I don't mind helping you, but I will only do it if you promise me something."

"What is it?" They both asked him simultaneously.

"Promise me that you're not deceiving me so that you can leave this place and cause trouble outside. If you break your promise, I will take full responsibility and do everything in my power to stop you."

As much as he wanted to trust these shadowy figures and believe they are who they say they are, he can never be too careful, and there was no way for him to know whether they are telling the truth or not.

"..."

The two shadowy figures turned to look at each other for a moment before raising their hands, almost like they were swearing an oath.

"I, Yu Ning, with heaven as my witness, swear that I am not deceiving you! If I deceive you, may the heavens shatter my soul into a thousand pieces!" The Immortal Fairy swore in a sincere voice.

"I, Ji Ran, with heaven as my witness, swear that I am not deceiving you! If I deceive you, may the heavens shatter my soul into a thousand pieces!"
The Sect Master swore next.

After their swearing ended, Yuan could feel a profound aura suddenly appear in the atmosphere.

"Are you satisfied, young man? We don't have any ulterior motives, nor are we trying to deceive you. We are only trying to leave this hell that has kept us in the darkness for countless years." Ji Ran, the Sect Master, said to him.

"Now that we made a heavenly oath, if we deceive you, the heavens will directly punish us by shattering our souls into a thousand pieces, and that brings us no merits."

Hearing their sincere voices, Yuan nodded, "Okay, I will help you guys get out of this place when I can."

[You have accepted the Hidden Quest: Banished Immortals!]

"Thank you, young man."

The both of them bowed to him in a respectful manner.

"You can call me Yuan," he nodded.

Sometime later, they arrived before a massive golden temple.

"Is this the treasure room?" Yuan asked the two Immortals who'd decided to linger around.

"Yes, this is the Dragon Treasury." Yu Ning said.

And she continued, "Since the Shadow Realm and this place isn't truly connected, we cannot enter this place, so you'll have to go alone."

Yuan nodded and approached the Dragon Treasury.

"Thank you for bringing me here and preventing the other spirits from bothering me," he said to them.

"It's nothing compared to what you'll be doing for us."

Yuan nodded, "I will try my best to reach Spirit Emperor and return to this place."

"There's no need to rush, Yuan. A few hundred years mean nothing to us here, much less a few years. The most important thing is to keep yourself safe and alive. Everything will be meaningless if you die, and it will also seal our fate." Yu Ning said to him.

"Don't forget about us." Ji Ran said in a joking tone.

Yuan chuckled and said, "Don't worry, I won't forget something this important. I will see you two later."

"The sooner the better." Ji Ran nodded.

Sometime later, Yuan entered the Dragon Treasury whilst the two Immortal spirits lingered around the place for a few more moments before disappearing like smoke.

Once Yuan entered the building through the main door that was already opened, he began descending an extremely long flight of stairs that took at least half an hour of straight walking.

If he had to take a guess, the treasure room was actually dozens of miles underground.

And although there were no windows or sources of light, the place was dimly lit, almost as though there were invisible candles in the place.

Once he reached the bottom, Yuan was greeted by another set of doors.

This time, the doors were actually sealed shut, and there were two dragons engraved on each side of the doors.

Yuan took a deep breath and approached the doors, and he tried to push it open.

However, the doors remained tightly shut.

"How do I enter this place? I should have the key— two of them at that." Yuan mumbled to himself.

It was at this moment one of the dragon engravings suddenly shot out a golden beam from its eyes, landing directly on Yuan's body.

The beam only lasted for a few seconds.

Once it disappeared, the doors suddenly began rumbling, and they slowly opened the next moment.

When the rumbling stopped, Yuan took another deep breath and entered the bright room ahead.

The air inside the room was unnaturally cool, almost like there was an air conditioner inside, and the room was smaller than Yuan had expected.

Inside the treasure room that was only slightly larger than an ordinary store, there were around a dozen display cases placed orderly around the room.

This scenery reminded him of Feng Yuxiang's store before she closed it down.

Yuan immediately walked around the room and looked at the treasures in the display cases.

[Bloody Dragon Spear]

[Grade: Ancient]

[Quality: Peak]

[Physical Strength required: 200,000]

[Mental Strength required: 350,000]

[Description: A powerful spear refined with dragon blood. Increases damage by 500%. Increases weapon penetration by 1,000%.]

"What a powerful treasure..." Yuan subconsciously went to open the display case to take a closer look at the spear.

However, a notification appeared in front of him when he touched the display case.

[Would you like to use 1x Dragon Temple Treasure Key to open the display case?]

"What? Does this mean I can only take one treasure for every key I have?" Yuan mumbled in a dazed voice, feeling lucky that he'd obtained a second key now, as this meant he could obtain an extra treasure in this place.

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Chapter 419 - Leaving The Dragon Temple

Once he realized that he could only pick two treasures from the dozen in the treasure room, Yuan proceeded to look at every single treasure carefully before making a decision.

"Oh? This looks like..." Yuan narrowed his eye when he saw a glass bottle that contained a single drop of blood inside.

[Dragon Blood]

[Description: A priceless treasure that will increase one's lifespan by 100,000 years and has the ability to awaken one's bloodline.]

As he'd expected, it was dragon blood. However, Yuan wasn't very excited about this drop of blood that would start a war in the cultivation world if known, and it was mostly because of the Dragon Ancestor's Blood Essence that's already in his possession.

Not only was the Dragon Ancestor's Blood Essence much more powerful than this ordinary blood, but he has also already awakened his bloodline, so unless he really wanted that 100,000 years of longevity on top of the 50,000 longevity he'd obtained from Feng Yuxiang's blood, this dragon blood was essentially useless to him.

Thus, after spending a few seconds on the dragon blood, Yuan moved onto the next treasure, which appeared to be a semi-transparent cloak.

[Invisible Dragon Cloak]

[Grade: Ancient]

[Mental Strength required: 200,000]

[Soul Strength required: 200,000]

[Quality: Peak]

[Description: A powerful cloak that turns completely invisible when worn. Increases base physical defenses by 100%. Negates all physical damage from Cultivators below Spirit King. Deflects all physical damage from treasures below Ancient-grade.]

"Oh, this is a very good treasure... As long as I have this, I don't have to worry about getting hit by physical attacks..." Yuan mumbled to himself, putting this Invisible Dragon Cloak at the top of his list.

The next treasure displayed was a single scale.

[Ancient Dragon Scale]

[Description: A near-indestructible material that can be used to forge or refine Ancient-grade treasures.]

Next in line was a cultivation technique that Yuan was very familiar with.

[Dragon's Gaze]

[Description: A technique created by the 'Great One'. A single gaze will cause Immortals to bow and the Heavens to tremble in fear! Used by Royal Families of the Dragon Race.]

"Dragon's Gaze? I would've probably picked this if I didn't already know it..." Yuan sighed.

The next treasure was also a cultivation technique.

[Relentless Dragon Overwhelms the Nine Heavens]

[Rank: Ancient]

[Description: A single fist to shatter the stars, another to rule the heavens. Consumes half of your overall spiritual energy to unleash a heaven-destroying attack with your fists.]

"What a powerful-sounding technique... Kind of reminds me of Feng Yuxiang's movement technique. It might come in handy when I cannot use my treasures." Yuan mumbled to himself.

He has already encountered multiple situations where he is restricted to using his fists, and he cannot rely on his weapons forever, so getting a fist technique might help him in the future.

The other treasures in the room were weapons and armors, but compared to the Invisible Dragon Cloak, they weren't too impressive, and Yuan wasn't in need of weapons or armors.

"Okay, I have decided. I am going to take the Invisible Dragon Cloak and the Relentless Dragon Overwhelms the Nine Heavens technique!"

[Would you like to use 1x Dragon Temple Treasure Key to open the display case?]

"Yes!"

[A Dragon Temple Treasure Key has been consumed]

After opening the display case that contained the Invisible Dragon Cloak, Yuan immediately wore it on his body like a cape.

Ding!

[Due to the Invisible Dragon Cloak, your Physical Defense has increased by 100%!]

[Physical Defense: 467,420]

The cloak disappeared the moment Yuan wore it, almost like it no longer exists. However, Yuan could still feel its presence as the owner of the treasure.

After wearing the cloak, Yuan went to open the second display case.

[Would you like to use 1x Dragon Temple Treasure Key to open the display case?]

"Yes!"

[A Dragon Temple Treasure Key has been consumed]

Yuan picked up the scroll that had been sitting inside the display case for god-knows-how-long and immediately stored it inside his spatial ring.

"What should I do now? I reached the limit of trials I can do, I have received the Great One's Legacy, and I even went to the treasure room. There's literally nothing left for me to do in here, and I still have a couple of days left in this place. Can I leave this place before the time limit?"

Yuan was already prepared to leave the Dragon Temple, but he wasn't too hasty and wanted to make sure that he wasn't missing anything in the treasure room.

Thus, he began looking around the place again, searching every nook and cranny with the Dragon's Gaze activated.

When he was satisfied, Yuan shouted out loud, "Great One! Can you hear me?! I would like to leave the Dragon Temple!"

A few moments of silence later, a profound voice suddenly resounded in the treasure room.

"Are you sure? Once you leave, you won't be able to return."

"Yes, I am sure. I have already done everything here." Yuan said.

"Everything, huh?"

A greyish cloud suddenly appeared in the air a few meters away from Yuan before transforming into an eye.

"So you have received my Legacy." The Great One could immediately tell at glance.

"And you even reached the treasure room that hasn't been opened since I created this place... Not bad... but not unexpected."

"I can take you outside if you wish, but before you leave, tell me one thing." The Great One said.

And it continued, "What do you plan on doing after you leave this place?"

"I don't really know. I guess I'll explore the Lower Heavens some more with my friends before I decide to challenge the Stairway to Heaven."

"I see..."

The Great One didn't say anything else, and its eye suddenly flickered with a profound light.

"Eh?"

Before he'd even realized, Yuan had been teleported outside the Dragon Temple, returning to the Dragon Fissure at the Dragon Essence Temple.

"Disciple Yuan?"

A surprised voice called out to him, causing him to turn around, and when he realized her identity, he mumbled in a low voice, "Senior Song?"

Chapter 420 - Heavenly War Of Immortals And Gods

"W-Where did you come from? You startled me for a second there." Song Ling'er said to him in a dazed voice.

And she continued, "What happened to the Dragon Temple? You're out earlier than I'd expected."

"I finished it earlier than I had expected as well." Yuan nodded.

"Well, this makes things much easier for me, anyway." Song Ling'er proceeded to store the zither into her storage ring.

And she continued afterward, "You should know why I'm here, so I won't beat around the bush. I'm here to recruit you to the Heavenly Melody Academy. Join my sect."

"I'm sorry, but I cannot join your sect." Yuan immediately refused her offer.

Song Ling'er wasn't surprised by his response. In fact, she had expected it.

After taking a deep breath, she asked him, "What do I have to do in order for you to join my sect?"

"I'm sorry, but I don't intend on joining another sect while I am in the Lower Heavens, and I plan on leaving this place in the near future," Yuan said.

Song Ling'er sighed after hearing his words, and she said afterward, "I understand—"

However, she suddenly stopped in the middle of her speech, and she narrowed her eyes at him.

"Y-You... Why are you emitting the aura of a Spirit Grandmaster?" Song Ling'er suddenly realized this fact that even Long Yijun and the others had missed because they were unable to detect Yuan's cultivation base, who was a Spirit Grandmaster, whilst being a Spirit Master unless they really focused on him.

"I am currently at the 3rd level Spirit Grandmaster," Yuan revealed his cultivation base in a casual voice, making it sound like it was normal for a young man like him to be a Spirit Grandmaster.

"T-Third level Spirit Grandmaster?! That's two whole levels higher than mine!" Song Ling'er exclaimed.

"Did the Mystic Realm affect your cultivation that much? You were only a first level Spirit Master before you entered!"

Yuan nodded, "Yes, a lot of things happened while I was inside, and my cultivation benefited a lot from it."

"Good heavens... And to think you were only a Spirit Warrior during the zither competition. At this rate, you'll reach Spirit Lord by next month..." Song Ling'er said, feeling all of her motivation to recruit him shattering into a thousand pieces.

After all, who in their right mind would be shameless enough to ask a Spirit Grandmaster to become a disciple?

If Yuan joins the Heavenly Melody Academy, he wouldn't be joining as a disciple but as the Sect Master instead!

"Young Master! You're out already?" The door to the building a few meters from them suddenly opened, and Feng Yuxiang and the others could be seen walking out of the building a moment later.

"Yuan? I thought you had an entire week inside. Did something happen?" Meixiu asked him.

Yuan shook his head and said, "No, I have accomplished everything I could inside, and it would simply be a waste of time if I continued to stay inside when there's nothing else to do, so I decided to leave early."

"Does this mean you'll be leaving the Dragon Essence Temple now?" Xiao Hua asked him.

Yuan nodded, "Yes, but I cannot just leave without saying anything. I still have to let the Sect Master and the others know."

"Wait... You're leaving the Dragon Essence Temple already?" Song Ling'er asked him in a dumbfounded voice.

"Yes."

"What are you going to do after you leave?"

"I'm going to explore the Lower Heavens some more with my friends before I ascend," he said.

"..."

After a moment of silence, Song Ling'er sighed, "Fine... I give up trying to recruit you."

And she continued, "However, I have another offer for you now."

"Before you leave the Lower Heavens, can you visit the Heavenly Melody Academy at least once?"

"That I can do." Yuan quickly accepted her offer.

"I am also interested in what a sect that's focused on music is like."

"Great! Let me know before you arrive so I can prepare for it." Song Ling'er reached into her robes and retrieved a jade slip before handing it to

Yuan.

"This is my communication jade slip. You can contact me for other things if you wish." Song Ling'er said.

"Okay. I will definitely visit the Heavenly Melody Academy once before I leave." Yuan nodded.

"It's a promise. Then I will see you then." Song Ling'er said before flying away.

After Song Ling'er left the scene, Feng Yuxiang turned to look at Yuan and asked him, "Did you obtain anything good in the Dragon Temple?"

Yuan nodded, "I will tell you all about it, but let's sit down first."

They proceeded to enter the building Long Yijun left behind.

Once they were all seated, Yuan began recalling his experience in the Dragon Temple.

Although they were surprised about the priceless treasures he'd obtained, they were more shocked about the Shadow Realm and the banished Immortals within.

"Immortals from the Primordial Era... That's a really long time ago, and I mean really, really long ago." Feng Yuxiang said.

"How long are we talking about? A few hundred thousand years?" Yuan asked.

Feng Yuxiang chuckled and said, "More like a few hundred million years ago."

"What?! That long?!" Yuan was greatly shocked to learn this.

Does this mean the banished Immortals had been living in that hell for at least a few hundred million years? His pity for them grew even more.

"As for what they said regarding the Celestial Emperor... Indeed, that has happened in the past. It was called the Heavenly War of Immortals and Gods, and it was one of the first large-scale wars to happen in the Nine Heavens. Tens of thousands of Immortals and many Gods perished during that war. Though, I don't know much about it besides what I just said since it'd happened really long ago." Feng Yuxiang said.

"As for whether they can be trusted or not... I really can't tell you that since I don't know either of them. Ethereal Immortal Fairy and the Sect Master of the Immortal Monastery... I have never heard of them before, but if you go to the upper heavens, you might find more information about them."

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Chapter 421 - Announcing His Departure

After recalling his experience to them, Yuan showed off his newly acquired treasure.

"What? You had that on you the entire time? I didn't even notice it!" Feng Yuxiang was surprised when Yuan suddenly removed the Invisible Dragon Cloak from his body, allowing the others to see it.

"An Ancient-grade treasure... As expected of the Great One... He's known for having the biggest collection of treasures in the Nine Heavens." Feng Yuxiang sighed in admiration, as she has heard of countless legends about the Great One in the upper heavens.

Sometime later, Yuan said, "Okay, I am going to speak with the Sect Master now regarding my departure."

After the others returned to his body, Yuan and Meixiu returned to the Dragon Essence Temple.

"Sect Master, are you there?" Yuan knocked on the Sect Master's headquarters.

"Disciple Yuan? I'm a little busy right now, but you can enter. I'll be with you after I'm done here." Long Yijun's voice resounded a moment later.

Yuan proceeded to open the door and enter the building, and to his surprise, there were many people gathered inside at this moment.

Elder Xuan and Elder Shang were also there alongside four unfamiliar faces.

However, it was clear to Yuan at a glance that the atmosphere was an unpleasant one.

"That's Disciple Yuan? The person who opened the Mystic Pagoda and refused to ascend with Senior Nie?"

One of the people Yuan didn't recognize mumbled in a surprised voice.

"Disciple Yuan, you can take a seat over there for now. This won't take long." Long Yijun said to them.

And then he returned to the four individuals and said, "Anyways, back to our topic. I am willing to return the Divine-grade treasures you'd lost to our Dragon Essence Temple during the bet, but it won't be for free."

"100,000 spirit stones. That is the amount I am willing to sell it for— no more, no less."

"100,000 spirit stones?! Are you out of your damn mind, Long Yijun?! That's one billion gold! Even Divine-grade treasures aren't worth that much!" One of the guests there said.

"That's right! The last time a Divine-grade treasure was sold, it was sold for around 600 million gold!" Another one said.

"While that is true, it is also true that these Divine-grade treasures are of the peak quality and an inheritance treasure for your sects. Surely, they must be worth more than an ordinary Divine-grade treasure sold in an auction house... Am I right?" Long Yijun said to them, refusing to lower the cost.

If he manages to sell these four Divine-grade treasures for 400,000 spirit stones, that would supply their sect for many years to come.

"You...!"

The four Sect Masters was speechless. As much as they wanted to refute Long Yijun's claims, they weren't in the position. After all, they must reclaim their sects' treasure at all cost, or their ancestors might curse them from their graves.

"Look, I am not the one standing between you and your treasure— you are. If you just hand over 100,000 spirit stones, I would be more than happy to return your treasures that I'd rightfully won." Long Yijun continued to speak.

"In fact, there are many people who are eyeing these treasures at this moment, and they'd be more than willing to pay 100,000 spirit stones for them. I am giving you guys the opportunity to reclaim them first since I am a kind man. If you don't want them, I will have no choice but to sell them to other people."

When the four Sect Masters heard Long Yijun's shameless words, they nearly coughed up a mouthful of blood from anger. However, they managed to refrain themselves from doing so, and after a long moment of silence, one of them said, "Fine! I will pay 100,000 spirit stones! Give me three days to prepare the money!"

Once one of them surrendered, the others began surrendering as well, as they didn't want to risk Long Yijun selling their treasures to other sects, something they were certain he was shameless enough to do.

"Thank you all for your business!"

The four Sect Masters left the place shortly after whilst Long Yijun kept a wide smile on his face even after they left.

"Hahaha! A bunch of idiots!" Long Yijun laughed out loud after they left.

He then turned to look at Yuan and said, "You're out earlier than I'd expected. Did something happen?"

He repeated what Meixiu said not long ago.

"Nothing happened. I just finished faster than anticipated. That's all," he said.

"If that's the case, then I hope you have obtained some good treasures whilst inside. Of course, you don't have to tell me anything." Long Yijun

said to him.

"Anyways, do you have anything else for me?"

Yuan nodded and said, "I'm here to announce my departure from the Dragon Essence Temple."

"Eh?"

Everyone in the room looked at him with widened eyes, their expressions filled with surprise.

"Y-You're going to leave the sect? Why? Did we do something wrong? Or did someone offend you again?" Elder Shang was the first to snap out of her daze and asked him.

Yuan shook his head and said, "No, the sect didn't do anything wrong. It's just that I think I have experienced enough of what it's like to be a disciple, and that it's about time I leave."

After a moment of silence, Long Yijun sighed, "I see... So it's that time, huh? I knew you wouldn't stay in the sect for long, but to think that day would come so soon."

"Of course, I won't even try to convince you to stay. As much as I want you to stay here, we are well aware that you don't belong to this place. It's simply too small for someone like you. I'm glad you decided to leave after the Mystic Realm. What do you plan on doing after you leave?"

Long Yijun gave up rather quickly and asked him.

Chapter 422 - Watching Yuan Cultivate

"I plan on exploring the Lower Heavens some more with my friends before I challenge the Stairway to Heaven," said Yuan after Long Yijun asked for his plans.

"The Stairway to Heaven, huh... Well, there's no doubt that you would be able to overcome this challenge that over 99 percent can't surpass." Long Yijun nodded.

And he continued, "When do you plan on leaving?"

"I would like to say goodbye to a few people before I leave, but I should leave within the next few days," Yuan said.

"I understand." Long Yijun said.

"If you need anything from us, just let us know. Although you may be leaving, your contribution to the sect is worth more than what every single disciple has contributed in the last hundred years combined."

Yuan nodded, and he left with Meixiu shortly after.

Once Yuan left the scene, Long Yijun sat down and sighed, "The Dragon Essence Temple won't feel the same without him even though he only recently joined the sect."

"At least he's not leaving our sect to join another sect, as that would be devastating." Elder Shan said.

"I'm honestly surprised that he lasted this long, especially with how the others have treated him. If I was him, I would've probably left a long time ago." Elder Xuan said.

"Are we going to tell the disciples?" Elder Shan suddenly asked.

After all, if someone like Yuan suddenly disappeared from the sect, the disciples would question it, as Yuan was someone who'd obtained the Obsidian Dragon Medallion.

"There's no need for them to know, as that would undoubtedly reach the ears of our competitions. If they know Yuan is gone, who knows what they'll do." Long Yijun said.

"But they will find out eventually." Elder Xuan said.

"Someone as famous as Disciple Yuan, even if nobody knows his real identity or face, they will sooner or later realize that he's missing from the sect. What are we going to do then?" Elder Shan asked.

"I am well aware that we cannot keep this a secret forever. However, the longer we keep this a secret, the more time we have to prepare for whatever comes at us."

"That makes sense." Elder Shan agreed.

"Let the other high-ranking sect elders know of Disciple Yuan's departure. The disciples may not need to know, but it's better if the others in the circle knew about it."

"Okay."

Meanwhile, after Yuan left the Sect Master's headquarters, he returned to his own living quarters, but he didn't go inside.

Instead, he went to knock on Disciple Min's door.

"Disciple Yuan? You've finished already?" Min Li was pleasantly surprised to see him so quickly, as she was prepared to wait at least a few weeks

before speaking with him again.

Yuan nodded and said, "I am also here to announce that I will be leaving the Dragon Essence Temple soon— probably within the next few days."

"I see..." Min Li wasn't surprised when she heard that he was leaving, as he'd already shared this with her before he entered the Dragon Temple.

"What should I do now? Do you want me to leave the sect as well?" Min Li asked him.

"No, you don't need to do that." Yuan shook his head and said, "You can stay in the Dragon Essence Temple and continue to train yourself. Once it's time for me to challenge the Stairway to Heaven, I will return to take you with me."

"You promise?" Min Li said with a slightly worried frown on her face, as she was worried that Yuan might forget about her or even worse, abandon her, and her life's basically in his hands now due to her situation.

"I promise," Yuan said in a sincere voice.

"Okay, I will trust you." Min Li nodded.

Sometime later, Yuan logged off the game with Meixiu.

After dinner, Yuan began cultivating for the night.

"Yuan, I am curious. What does cultivating in the real world look like? Do you think I can watch you cultivate a little tonight?" Meixiu suddenly asked him.

"Okay. I don't mind." Yuan said. Now that they know about his cultivation in the real world, there was no reason for him to keep hiding it.

Thus, Meixiu went to Yuan's room and waited for him to cultivate.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan began circulating his Dantian and absorbing the spiritual energy in the air.

"This is... cultivation?"

Meixiu was speechless when a small gust of wind suddenly picked up in the room despite the closed windows, and the wind appeared to be gathering around the bed Yuan was sleeping on.

Furthermore, there appeared to be a subtle glow around Yuan's body that would grow brighter as he continued to cultivate longer.

Sometime later, once she'd seen enough, Meixiu returned to her own room to sleep, yet she couldn't stop thinking about Yuan cultivating, as it was so mythical.

The following morning, after breakfast, Yuan and Meixiu entered Cultivation Online together.

"I'm going to say goodbye to Disciple Xuan and Disciple Fei today," Yuan said to Min Li when he saw her looking at him from the window.

Min Li nodded and didn't say anything else.

Yuan decided to go see Fei Yuyan first, and on his way to Fei Yuyan's living quarters, every disciple in the sect would either greet him from afar or approach him and greet him.

"Good morning, Senior apprentice-brother Yuan."

"Good morning, Senior Disciple Yuan."

By now, every single disciple in the sect knew about the unrivaled genius known as Disciple Yuan and his unique appearance, as Yuan would always wear a mask wherever he went.

In fact, besides a few people, nobody knew what Yuan looked like behind his mask. Although they were certainly curious, nobody actually dared to ask him to remove his mask, as they feared that it might offend him.

Once he reached the border separating the Outer Court and the Inner Court, the sect elder guarding the entrance allowed Yuan to enter the Inner Court

without any problems, and Yuan continued to make his way to Fei Yuyan's living quarters.

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Chapter 423 - I Can Take You With Me

Knock *Knock*

Yuan knocked on Fei Yuyan's door after arriving at her doorsteps.

A few moments later, Fei Yuyan opened the door slightly just enough for Yuan to see one of her eyes through the thin crack.

"Disciple Yuan?"

Once Fei Yuyan noticed who it was, she opened the door wider, and Yuan could see her wearing a towel, looking like she'd just gotten out of the bath, her hair still wet.

If it was anyone else, Fei Yuyan wouldn't have revealed such an enticing sight, but since it was Yuan, she wanted to act a little bold.

"Umm... I can wait until you're prepared." Yuan said.

"I-It's okay. Come inside." Fei Yuyan said with a slightly rosy face.

It was at this moment Fei Yuyan noticed Meixiu following behind him.

"Who is she?" Fei Yuyan asked, as this was their first meeting.

"This is my friend, Meixiu." Yuan gave a quick introduction.

"I-I see..." Fei Yuyan nodded.

'What a beauty... I wonder if they're anything more than just friends...' Fei Yuyan wondered inwardly.

Once they were inside, Yuan sat on the couch whilst Fei Yuyan sat on the opposite side.

Of course, she was still in nothing but her towel, and her bare slender legs were in full view.

Meixiu was speechless. Either female disciples in the cultivation world are usually this bold or this Fei Yuyan is very special.

"Have you been practicing the Divine-grade zither technique?" Yuan asked her once he sat down.

Fei Yuyan nodded, "Yes, I have been practicing it every day since I obtained it."

"Oh, right. I never got to thank you for giving me the technique. Thank you, Disciple Yuan."

"You don't have to thank me. On the other hand, I'm sorry I wasn't able to hand it to you personally. I tried looking for you, but you were in closed cultivation according to Elder Shan."

"Anyways, let's get to the main reason I'm here today. I'm here to say goodbye."

"Eh?" Fei Yuyan's face immediately froze after hearing his words.

At first, she was puzzled, then she was shocked.

"G-Goodbye? Are you going somewhere?" Fei Yuyan asked him in a trembling voice.

Yuan nodded and said, "I am going to leave the Dragon Essence Temple soon."

"What?! That's too sudden!"

Fei Yuyan suddenly stood up from her seat, and because of how fast she stood up, the towel covering her body came loose and dropped onto the ground before she could even react.

"..."

Yuan's eyes widened as he stared at Fei Yuyan's seemingly peerless naked body that was directly in front of his face.

"Ahem!"

Meixiu suddenly lifted her arm and blocked Yuan's view.

"Ahh!"

It was at this moment Fei Yuyan finally realized that she was naked and reacted, and she quickly went to pick up the towel to cover herself again, but it was already too late, as Yuan had seen everything.

"I-I'm sorry! I will be right back!"

Fei Yuyan then rushed to her room to wear her clothes.

A few minutes later, Fei Yuyan returned to the living room, but her face was still as red as a tomato.

"Are you okay?" Yuan asked her in a perfectly calm manner.

"Y-Yeah... I'm sorry you had to see such a sight..." Fei Yuyan responded in a mosquito-like voice.

"A-Anyways, you're going to leave the sect soon, right? Can I ask why?" She quickly changed the subject.

Yuan nodded and said, "I don't really have a particular reason. It's just that I think I have enough experience."

"Experience?"

"Yes. I joined the Dragon Essence Temple for experience since I wanted to know what it was like to be a disciple. I never intended to stay very long, either."

"Can I ask what you're going to do afterward?"

"I am going to explore the Lower Heavens some more with my friends before I ascend through the Stairway to Heaven."

"Stairway to Heaven... You're really different from the rest of us. I cannot even imagine challenging it, yet you're already going to challenge it soon." Fei Yuyan sighed.

She then looked up at the ceiling and sighed, "Spirit Heaven, huh? To be completely honest, I also want to ascend, but with my talents, I know it's not going to happen."

"If you want, I can take you with me." Yuan suddenly suggested.

"What?" Fei Yuyan looked at him with wide eyes.

"I will be bringing Disciple Min with me when I challenge the Stairway to Heaven, and it won't make much of a difference if I take you with me as well... I think..." Yuan said.

"I... I don't know what to say, really..." Fei Yuyan mumbled in a dazed voice.

"You don't have to make a decision now. I will ask you again when I return to pick up Disciple Min." Yuan said.

"Okay..." Fei Yuyan nodded with a serious look on her face.

Sometime later, after speaking some more with Fei Yuyan, Yuan left her place and headed to Xuan Wuhan's living quarters.

"He... He saw me naked... What a blunder!" Fei Yuyan laid on the couch in a dazed manner for many minutes even after Yuan left her place.

After leaving Fei Yuyan's place, Yuan realized that he's never been to Xuan Wuhan's living quarters.

Thus, he contacted Elder Xuan to ask for directions.

"Thank you, Senior Xuan."

Once he knew where to go, Yuan went directly to Xuan Wuhan's living quarters.

However, on his way to Xuan Wuhan's place, Yuan stopped his tracks when an unfamiliar face suddenly walked in front of him and blocked his path.

"You're Disciple Yuan, right?" This handsome young man asked him.

"Yes, but who are you?" Yuan asked.

"Name's Gu Tan from one of the Seven Legacy Families— the Gu Family, and I am here to recruit you to the Gu Family." This young man introduced himself.

And because of his impression of the Min Family, Yuan immediately frowned after hearing that he was from one of the Seven Legacy Families.

"Sorry, but I am going to have to refuse." Yuan immediately rejected the Gu Family's invitation, leaving Gu Tan speechless.

Chapter 424 - A Small Favor

"W-Wait... Let's not be so hasty. You haven't even given me a chance to explain the benefits..." Gu Tan immediately began panicking, as he didn't expect to be rejected so quickly.

"I don't need to hear the benefits because I won't join the Gu Family no matter what you offer me. Sorry." Yuan rejected him once again, this time being more stern, even a little brutal.

Gu Tan began sweating profusely after hearing this, and he asked, "C-Can I at least ask why you're refusing us? Did you already join another family?"

"No. I just don't want to join any families, especially the Seven Legacy Families." Yuan answered.

Gu Tan wondered if one of the Seven Legacy Families had offended him.

"I-It seems like something has happened between one of the Seven Legacy Families and you, but I can promise you that our Gu Family is different." Gu Tan tried a different approach.

However, Yuan still shook his head and said, "Don't bother. I won't join."

And without waiting for Gu Tan to respond, Yuan walked around him and continued his journey to Xuan Wuhan's living quarters.

Of course, Gu Tan wasn't willing to give up so easily, as his parents had assigned him to recruit Yuan with his head on the line.

Thus, he proceeded to follow Yuan and continue to try and recruit him.

"What do you desire, Disciple Yuan? Do you want wealth? Fame? Power? The Gu Family will do everything in their power to fulfill your dreams. If needed, we'll even get the Gu Family from the Spirit Heaven to help."

"I desire for you to leave me alone now. If you cannot do even such a simple thing, what makes you think you can help me with the other stuff?" Yuan said to him.

Gu Tan was speechless, and he immediately stopped following Yuan after hearing his response.

'Looks like I will have to give up for now and ask him again later. Maybe he's just in a bad mood.' Gu Tan tried to soothe himself.

About ten minutes after Gu Tan left Yuan alone, another individual blocked his path.

This time, it was a pretty young lady around Min Li's age.

"Hello, are you Disciple Yuan?" The young lady greeted him with a beautiful smile on her face.

"I am. How can I help you?"

"I'm Xue Yixin, and I was wondering if you have some time to spare so we can talk." This young lady spoke with an enchanting expression on her face.

"What do you want to talk about? I'm busy right now, so we'll have to do it later."

"Are you sure you can't delay it for me? It won't take long... Or it can take as long as you want it to..." This young lady then slightly lowered her body whilst spreading the clothes around her neck, revealing two large peaks without showing everything.

Meixiu frowned when she saw this, and she quickly grabbed Yuan's arm before pulling him away.

"Let's go, Yuan. This girl is a dangerous one," she said to him.

When Xue Yixin saw this, she quickly chased after them and said, "W-Wait! I'm not someone suspicious! I'm from the Xue Family, one of the Seven Legacy Families!"

Xue Yixin hoped that her background would change the situation, but to her surprise, it only made the situation worse.

"Sorry, but if you're here to recruit me to the Xue Family, I will have to decline. I have already refused to join the Gu Family a few minutes ago. My decision won't change now even if you're from a different family." Yuan stopped for a moment to reject her before walking again.

"Uhh..."

The young lady was speechless, and she stood there like a statue with a dazed expression on her face.

Sometime later, Yuan finally arrived at Xuan Wuhan's living quarters.

Knock *Knock*

Yuan patiently waited for Xuan Wuhan to appear after knocking on the doors.

A few moments later, the door opened.

"Hello, Yuan." Xuan Wuhan greeted him, yet something felt off about it.

It was like she had been expecting him.

And just as he'd suspected, Xuan Wuhan said, "I have been expecting you. You're here to say goodbye, right?"

Yuan nodded in a slightly dazed manner.

"My grandfather told me about it yesterday," she continued, explaining to him how she found out.

"Oh, I see..."

"Although you may be leaving soon, I am still glad that you decided to join. Your contribution to the sect has far exceeded my expectations. Thank you, Yuan." Xuan Wuhan said with a beautiful smile on her face.

"I should be thanking you. It was because of your suggestion that I decided to join. If not for you, I would've probably never entered the Dragon Essence Temple or experienced all of the things I had experienced while in the sect. Therefore, thank you. If you need anything, just let me know!"

"If you want to thank me, I have an idea." Xuan Wuhan suddenly chuckled.

"What is it?"

"Before I respond, can I ask you a question?"

Yuan nodded.

Xuan Wuhan then turned to look at Meixiu who was standing behind him.

"Is she your girlfriend?" she asked, taking Meixiu by surprise.

"N-No... I am not..." Meixiu quickly responded.

"I see, then I guess it's fine." Xuan Wuhan mumbled in a low voice before turning to look at Yuan.

"Can you do me a small favor by closing your eyes for a moment?"

Yuan nodded and closed his eyes without any questions.

The next moment, Xuan Wuhan took a step forward with her hands reaching for Yuan's mask.

Once Xuan Wuhan got ahold of the mask, she removed it slightly before approaching his revealed face with her lips, kissing him on the cheeks a second later.

"Eh?"

Yuan opened his eyes when he suddenly felt a soft sensation pressing against the left side of his cheeks, but by the time his eyes opened, Xuan Wuhan had already removed her lips and stepped back with a rosy complexion on her face.

"Goodbye, Yuan. This is the best I can do for now, but if you come back later, I might be prepared to do a little more by then." Xuan Wuhan said with an embarrassed yet bright smile on her face before running back inside the building and slamming the door shut, leaving Yuan and Meixiu speechless.

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Chapter 425 - Core Disciple

After Xuan Wuhan kissed him on the cheeks and went back inside her house, Yuan touched the spot she kissed with a dazed look on his face, the sensation of her soft lips still lingering on his cheeks.

"What was that about?" He mumbled in a low voice.

'The girls in the cultivation world... They are truly bold...' Meixiu sighed inwardly.

If she had such boldness, what would her situation be like right now?

After standing in front of Xuan Wuhan's living quarters for a couple of moments, Yuan and Meixiu left the scene.

"Are you sure about this decision?"

Inside Xuan Wuhan's living quarters, Elder Xuan sat on the couch with a cup of tea in his hands.

A bittersweet smile appeared on Xuan Wuhan's face, and she said, "I am satisfied with just that. I know my limits. He and I... we live in two separate worlds. There's no way I am worthy to follow him."

"You're thinking too much. It's not about your worth, but whether he'll accept you or not, and if you don't ask him, how will he know, much less accept you?"

"I-I think I was pretty obvious with my actions just now..." Xuan Wuhan said in a dumbfounded voice.

"Haha... You underestimate him, Wuhan. Yuan... He's a special fellow who's also quite naive and innocent. He probably won't understand the meaning behind your actions unless you tell him straight."

Xuan Wuhan sighed, "It is what is it... I have already said my goodbyes. Even I don't have the guts to approach him after what happened just now. I will need at least a few months to recover."

"Do whatever you want, I guess..." Elder Xuan said to her, and after finishing his tea, he left her place.

Meanwhile, Yuan went to find Elder Shan at the Blossom Peak.

Once they arrived, Yuan noticed Elder Shan giving lectures to her disciple right outside her living quarters just like his last visit.

"I'm sorry to disturb your lecture again, Senior Shan." Yuan approached them.

"That is..."

This time, Elder Shan's disciples looked at Yuan in a different light, almost like they were filled with admiration.

"Disciple Yuan? Do you need anything from me? And you don't have to worry about disturbing us. I'm not really lecturing them," she said to him.

Yuan then said, "I know you already know this, but I want to say goodbye formally."

"Thank you for everything, Elder Shan." Yuan lowered his head a little to pay his respects.

"W-Why are you thanking me? I barely taught you anything. In fact, I should be the one thanking you..." Elder Shan was taken aback.

"That's not true, Senior Shan. I have learned a lot from you, and it's always a pleasant feeling with you around."

Elder Shan couldn't help but smile after hearing Yuan's words, and she spoke in an enchanting voice, "Are you trying to court me before you leave? It's working pretty well. But alas, if only I was a little younger."

"Eh?" Yuan was puzzled by her words. What did she mean by 'courting' her?

"Good luck out there, Yuan, and most importantly, stay safe." Elder Shan said to him.

Yuan nodded. "I will."

"Before you go."

Elder Shan suddenly stepped forward with her arms spread.

The next second, she embraced Yuan tightly.

After a few moments of physical contact, Elder Shan released him and stepped back.

"I hope to see you at least one more time before you leave for the Spirit Heaven," she said.

"I will definitely return before I leave," Yuan said.

"It's a promise."

Sometime later, Yuan left the Blossom Peak with Meixiu.

"Master... what was that about? Why did he make it seem like he'll be leaving the sect?" One of her disciples asked.

"Because he is leaving the sect." Elder Shan said.

And she quickly followed up with, "Keep this a secret, though. If I hear that you've opened your mouth about this matter to others, I will disown you as my disciple."

"I-I understand, Master. I won't tell a single soul!"

They all swore with nervous looks on their faces.

Elder Shan then turned to look at Yuan's disappearing figure in the distance.

'If only I had met you earlier...' she sighed inwardly.

After leaving the Blossom Peak, Yuan went to look for Elder Xuan.

"Here to say goodbye?" Elder Xuan greeted him with a smile at the door.

"Yes. I want to thank you for everything you've done for me." Yuan said to him.

"Hahaha... I've only brought you to places, and it was my job. You don't have to thank me."

Yuan and Elder Xuan proceeded to spend a few minutes chatting with each other.

"I would give you a farewell gift, but I really don't know what to give you, as anything I give you would become obsolete or worthless very quickly knowing your insane talents and progress, especially once you go to the Spirit Heavens."

"You don't need to give me anything. I have already received enough from you and everyone else in this sect."

"Okay. Then good luck out there and achieve great things. I'm sure I will still hear your name even after you leave." Elder Xuan said.

Sometime later, Yuan went to visit the other high-ranking sect elders despite spending very little time with them.

In the end, Yuan returned to the Sect Master's headquarters.

"Enter."

Long Yijun's voice resounded after Yuan knocked on the door.

"Sect Master, I'm here to say my goodbyes and to hand in my disciple uniform."

Yuan said as he held his Inner Court uniform in his hands.

Long Yijun looked at the uniform for a moment before speaking with a smile on his face, "Keep it."

"Normally, a disciple would have to hand in their uniform once they leave the sect, but I want you to keep it. In fact, I have even prepared the Core Disciple's uniform for you, as I will be promoting you to Core Disciple as of this moment."

Long Yijun said as he retrieved a set of uniforms meant for Core Disciples and placed it on the table before him.

"This is..." Yuan was at loss for words.

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Chapter 426 - Leaving The Dragon Essence Temple

"I wish you the best of luck outside in the real cultivation world, Disciple Yuan... Even though you probably won't need it." Long Yijun said to him with a smile.

"Thank you, Sect Master." Yuan accepted the Core Disciple's uniform before storing it inside the Dragon Spatial Ring alongside his Inner Court Disciple's uniform.

Sometime later, Yuan left the place and proceeded to make his way towards the gates of the sect. Although he could simply fly away, he wanted to leave this place properly.

The moment Yuan left the Dragon Essence Temple, Xiao Hua appeared from her necklace, and she said, "Now that Brother Yuan is finally finished with this place, Xiao Hua can stop hiding as well."

"How was your experience, Brother Yuan?" Xiao Hua asked him.

After all, the only reason she hid inside the necklace this entire time was to give Yuan some independence whilst he experienced the life of a disciple in a sect.

"It was great. I have learned a lot of things about cultivators and the cultivation world in general. Though, I could've probably remained a disciple there for a little longer."

However, Xiao Hua shook her head and said, "Once Brother Yuan reached the top of the ranks in the sect, there is no longer any point for you to stay

there. It's just how sects work in general."

Yuan looked at her and asked, "Xiao Hua, have you been in a sect before?"

After a moment of silence, she nodded.

"What was it like over there? How is it compared to the Dragon Essence Temple?"

"Compared to the Dragon Essence Temple?"

A slight smile appeared on her face as she said, "The Dragon Essence Temple is like a playground for children in comparison."

"Eh? What do you mean by that?" Yuan raised his eyebrows in a puzzled manner, as there could be many meanings behind her words.

"The Dragon Essence Temple is a lawful and a peaceful place. Although there are some troublemakers, it's not unreasonable or cruel. However, the sect Xiao Hua has experienced before is the complete opposite, and there is only one rule—the strong is always right."

Yuan was speechless. Just what kind of sect is she talking about? And how come she had to go to such a place at such a young age?

Yuan wanted to ask her about her background, but he didn't want to intrude on her privacy. Furthermore, he'd already said that he would patiently wait until she willingly told him herself.

"What are we going to do now, Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang's voice suddenly resounded as she appeared in front of him.

"We're going to find Meixiu a cultivation technique now."

"Where are we going to look for a cultivation technique? It's not easy finding a good cultivation technique, and the ones you can find easily are generally low-rank cultivation techniques that aren't much better than the Basic Qi Gathering Technique." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Maybe we can look around auction houses to see if we can find one there — actually, I know where we can go."

"Where?"

"The Myriad of Techniques. It's also where I obtained the Demon Sealing Strike and Yu Rou's technique. I think we'll be able to find a good cultivation technique for Meixiu if we go there."

"The Myriad of Techniques, huh? I have always heard good things about them even in the upper heavens." Feng Yuxiang suddenly said.

"Eh? Wait a second... They exist in the upper heaven as well?" Yuan said in a surprised voice.

Feng Yuxiang nodded and said, "The Myriad of Techniques is a special shop that exists in many cities across the Nine Heavens, and rumor has it they're all owned by a single person. However, nobody really knows the identity of that person, as they have never seen him or her before."

"I see..."

Sometime later, Yuan said, "Then let's go to Spring City, where the store is."

"Spring City? Why do we have to go to Spring City?" Feng Yuxiang raised her eyebrows.

"Eh? Because that's where the Myriad of Techniques is?"

"But there's one even closer. It's in Long Chen City."

"Oh, really? I didn't know that, nor did we see it when we went there last time." Yuan said.

"Then let's go to Long Chen City."

Thus, Yuan proceeded to soar in the sky with the others whilst Feng Yuxiang carried Meixiu.

"Xiao Hua, I have always wanted to fly beside you without needing the flying sword ever since we flew together. I didn't think I'd get the chance to do so this quickly." Yuan said to her as they flew towards Long Chen City.

"Xiao Hua didn't expect Brother Yuan to grow so fast either," she nodded.

Yuan suddenly retrieved his flying sword and began flying on it instead.

"I think I still like flying on a sword better. It has a different feeling to it that flying normally doesn't." Yuan said.

Once they arrived at Long Chen City a few minutes later, they entered the city and began looking for the store.

After asking around, they found the Myriad of Techniques somewhat hidden in a narrow path in the middle of the city.

"Myriad of Techniques..." Xiao Hua looked at the storefront with a slight frown on her face, as she could still remember their last visit to this place and that powerful girl who greeted them at the door.

A few moments later, Yuan opened the door and entered the store.

"Welcome to Myriad of Techniques—"

A beautiful girl with a familiar face greeted them but stopped halfway through her sentence.

"Hm? You're that little Spirit King from the last time." The beautiful girl looked at Xiao Hua with a pleasantly surprised look on her face.

"You're... Zhu Yuying? What are you doing here?" Yuan was surprised to see the same girl who greeted them in Spring City in this store as well. Did she change locations? What a coincidence.

"Huh? That voice... You're the one who broke the Divine Crystal of Heavenly Fortune last time!" Zhu Yuying didn't immediately recognize Yuan because of the mask covering his face, and his cultivation base and aura were vastly different. However, she recognized his voice.

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Chapter 427 - Myriad Of Techniques

Zhu Yuying was surprised to see Yuan again, but most importantly, she was shocked to see that he'd somehow managed to reach Spirit Grandmaster in such a short time when he was still in the Lower Heavens!

It has only been a few weeks since their last visit, and he was only at the Spirit Warrior at that time. To think he achieved Spirit Grandmaster in such a short time— not even her friends would believe her if she told them about Yuan.

"Y-You... How did your cultivation rise so quickly?" Zhu Yuying couldn't help but ask him.

"It just happened." Yuan shrugged.

"It just happened, you say?" Zhu Yuying raised her eyebrows.

Nobody 'just happens to' increase their cultivation by two whole realms in such a short time unless they have experienced and survived many life-or-death situations.

Zhu Yuying cannot imagine how many trials Yuan had to pass in order to receive such a boost.

'He properly had to crawl through burning ground and survive countless near-death situations,' Zhu Yuying sighed inwardly in an admiring manner, completely oblivious of the truth.

"By the way, did you decide to change locations? What happened at the store in Spring City?" Yuan asked her.

Zhu Yuying chuckled and said, "I didn't change locations, silly. Every single Myriad of Techniques in the Nine Heavens are connected to each other through a single powerful formation, so no matter which store you go to, you will always end up in the same place."

"However, there is more to it. It's a little complicated, but I will try my best to explain it to you."

She cleared her throat and said, "Depending on which of the Nine Heavens you come from you will be teleported to a certain part of the Myriad of Techniques. There are only three floors in the store right now, but there are actually more floors— nine to be exact. If you come from the Lower Heavens, you can only access the first three floors."

"In order to access the higher floors, you must enter the store from the upper heavens, so if you enter from the Spirit Heaven, you will be able to access the fourth floor of the store."

"So you're technically not in the Lower Heavens right now but in some other dimension, which is why I can talk to people in the Lower Heavens, as I am not really in the Lower Heaven right now."

"I see... Although it's a little complicated, I think I understand the system." Yuan mumbled with a pondering look on his face.

"Anyways, if you have already had your destiny examined, you don't need to do it again."

Zhu Yuying showed them the Divine Crystal of Heavenly Fortune and continued to speak, "And I don't want you breaking it again. This crystal ball isn't cheap, after all."

A guilty smile appeared on Yuan's face when he recalled that incident.

Zhu Yuying proceeded to explain things to Meixiu and the others.

A few moments later, Meixiu and Feng Yuxiang placed their hands on the Divine Crystal of Heavenly Fortune, and to Zhu Yuying's surprise, they

both had a heavenly destiny.

"You too." Zhu Yuying suddenly said as she glanced at Yuan's wrist after Meixiu and Feng Yuxiang's turn, obviously talking to Lan Yingying.

Lan Yingying transformed into her human form and asked, "Do I have to do it even though I won't be buying anything?"

Zhu Yuying nodded, "Everyone that wants to enter must do it."

"Okay." Lan Yingying nodded and placed her hand on the crystal ball.

"Another heavenly destiny? I have never seen so many people with a heavenly destiny together before," she mumbled in a dazed voice.

It was almost like everyone in that group had a heavenly destiny.

'Does this have something to do with him?' Zhu Yuying looked at Yuan for a moment.

A few moments later, Zhu Yuying asked them, "So what are you guys here for today? Who's the one trying to buy a new technique? And what kind? Perhaps I can help you out."

"We're looking for a cultivation technique for her." Yuan pointed at Meixiu.

"I see... Do you have any special physique or bloodline? They can greatly affect your cultivation speed depending on the cultivation technique you choose." Zhu Yuying asked her.

Meixiu nodded and said, "I have the Spirit Severing Physique."

"S-Spirit Severing Physique? What a rare one... No wonder why you have a heavenly destiny." Zhu Yuying mumbled in a shocked voice.

"And you're too nonchalant about it. There are many people who covet your talents. If I were you, I wouldn't reveal your physique so easily to just anyone."

"I understand. Thank you for the advice." Meixiu nodded.

"Anyways, I know the perfect technique for you, but unfortunately, it's on the fourth floor... You know what? Give me a few minutes."

Zhu Yuying then lifted her head and said, "Master, are you busy?"

A few moments later, a voice resounded in her head, "I'm currently speaking with the Sect Master of the Nine Gods Hall and a few other individuals. Unless this is an emergency, save it for later."

"Well... That young man who broke the Divine Crystal of Heavenly Fortune has returned... I remember you told me to contact you if he ever returns."

"What? That youngster is back? Really?" Senior Bai said in a surprised voice.

"What does he want this time?" He then asked.

"He's here to pick a cultivation technique for his friend who has the Spirit Severing Physique."

"The Spirit Severing Physique? There should be the perfect technique for that on the fourth floor."

"I know, but that's the problem. He cannot access the fourth floor yet since he's still in the Lower Heavens, and I was wondering if I can go to the fourth floor to get the technique for him."

"..."

After a moment of silence, Senior Bai spoke, "Go ahead. Do my friend a favor and get that technique for him."

'Friend?!' Zhu Yuying was shocked when Senior Bai addressed Yuan as his 'friend'.

"Thank you, Master. I will let him know," she said afterward.

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Chapter 428 - Is There Something On Me?

After receiving permission, Zhu Yuying turned to look at Yuan and said with a smile on her face, "Master just gave me the permission to go to the fourth floor to get the cultivation technique, so if you don't mind, give me a couple of minutes to get it for you since you cannot go there."

Yuan nodded, "Thank you very much. Your Master is Senior Bai, right? Please thank him for me as well."

"I will. You can wait for me in the guest area over there." Zhu Yuying pointed in a certain direction before leaving the scene.

However, to everyone's surprise, Zhu Yuying returned a few moments later and said, "Yuan, my Master said he'd like to speak with you again if you don't mind."

"I don't mind." Yuan nodded.

"Great. Do you still remember the way to the third floor? I cannot go with you since I will be going a different way this time."

"I remember."

"Alright. My Master is currently busy, but he will finish things up as soon as possible before coming to you. You can wait for him at the door in the meantime."

After saying that, Zhu Yuying left for good this time.

"I will be right back," Yuan said to the ladies before going to the third floor whilst the others went to the guest area to sit around.

Once he reached the staircase to the third floor, the guards there turned to look at him.

"Only authorized individuals may go up." One of them said to him.

Since they were not the same guard as previously and they weren't told by Zhu Yuying about Yuan, they had no idea that Yuan was authorized by Senior Bai to go upstairs.

"Senior Bai said he'd like to speak with me," Yuan said to them.

"What? Master Bai?"

The two guards exchanged glances, both filled with shock. They have worked here for hundreds of years yet this is the first time someone was given permission to speak with Senior Bai.

"Do you have any proof?" One of them asked a moment later.

"Uhh... I don't think so..." Yuan shook his head.

"As much as I want to let you go up, I don't want to risk it. What if you're lying to me? Our job— No, our lives are on the line here." The guard then said.

Yuan was also wearing a mask, which made the guards naturally wary of him.

"How problematic..." Yuan mumbled.

Without Zhu Yuying, he didn't know how to speak with Senior Bai.

"Guess I will just have to wait here until Senior Bai realizes that I am not showing up and let him speak with you two," Yuan said to the guards, and he began standing there.

"Uhh..."

The two guards began sweating. If what Yuan had told them was true and they made Senior Bai wait, that would be as bad as listening to Yuan if he lied.

"Shit... What should we do? Should we play it safe and make him wait or let him go?" One of the guards whispered to the other.

"Why the heck are you asking me? You're the senior one! You decide!"

"Don't pull that bullshit on me! I was here only 3 days earlier than you!"

While the two guards pondered whether they should let Yuan go or wait, Zhu Yuying arrived at the fourth floor.

However, she was blocked by the person managing the entrance.

"What are you doing on my floor, Disciple Zhu?" A pretty young girl with sharp facial features stood before her with a cold expression on her face.

"Why do you care, Fei Xinyi? It's none of your business." Zhu Yuying coldly snorted.

"Because this is my floor, and as the boss, I am entitled to know your business here," she responded.

"Is that right?" Zhu Yuying remained calm.

"That's right."

"I am here under Master's direction. I think that's the most you need to know."

"What? Master?" Fei Xinyi immediately frowned.

"I swear... If you're using the Master as an excuse..."

"If you're doubting me, you can go ahead and ask the Master himself. Anyways, I am going to do my job." Zhu Yuying said before she walked around Fei Xinyi.

"A-As if I can do that! You know he doesn't like being bothered by insignificant matters!" Fei Xinyi said as she followed Zhu Yuying to see what she was up to.

After walking for a few minutes, Zhu Yuying stopped before a certain shelf that was filled with techniques.

"Let's see... Ah, here it is..." Zhu Yuying reached for the technique when she found it.

"You... What are you doing with that technique? Why would the Master need that technique? Something's not right here!" Fei Xinyi said with a frown on her face.

Zhu Yuying shrugged her shoulders and said, "I never said this was for the Master. I am only doing something for the Master."

"Hmph! I don't believe you! I am going to see what you're up to, and if you're up to no good, I am going to complain to the Master!"

"Do whatever you want." Zhu Yuying shrugged again, and she began making her way back to the first floor but with an additional person.

Meanwhile, back at the first floor, while Meixiu and the others waited for Yuan, Meixiu would stare at Lan Yingying silently— or more specifically, Lan Yingying's stomach, almost like she wanted to say something.

Lan Yingying noticed this and asked her, "Is there something on me?"

"No... I was just wondering about something..." Meixiu subconsciously responded, and she continued, "You're pregnant with Yuan's baby, right? How does it feel? Pregnancy."

"Excuse me? Pregnant? Who's pregnant? And whose baby?" Feng Yuxiang suddenly turned to look at them with her eyes as wide as saucers.

Even Xiao Hua was staring at them with wide eyes, almost like she was in disbelief.

Lan Yingying looked at Feng Yuxiang and explained, "I asked the Lord to impregnate me, and he agreed."

Then she returned to Meixiu and continued as though it was normal, "Although I have accepted his blood, I am not actually pregnant yet so I don't feel any different from usual."

Feng Yuxiang's jaw dropped to the ground after hearing Lan Yingying's words, and then she recalled Meixiu's sudden and confusing question about how Divine Beasts make babies when Yuan was still in the Mystic Realm.

'E-Everything makes sense now!' she cried inwardly, feeling a huge headache coming.

Chapter 429 - Visiting Senior Bai Again

"Y-You asked for the Young Master's blood...? Really?" Despite all of the evidence, Feng Yuxiang still doubted the situation and wanted to be absolutely sure that it was not a misunderstanding.

Lan Yingying nodded in a calm manner and said, "Yes. I should give birth in a thousand years."

"Good heavens... A Divine Beast getting impregnated by a human..." Feng Yuxiang mumbled in a dazed voice.

"Is that wrong?" Lan Yingying couldn't help but ask, as she wasn't aware of how things worked outside the Mystic Realm, and Feng Yuxiang was the first Divine Beast she had met besides her own family.

"I wouldn't say it's wrong since it's not a taboo or anything, but it's definitely frowned upon by most Divine Beasts, as they see humans as inferior beings. To be completely honest with you, I also used to look down on humans, but I learned my lesson after meeting the human who cursed my bloodline with the snap of his fingers..." Feng Yuxiang sighed.

"Cursed?" Lan Yingying tilted her head since this is her first time hearing about her situation.

"It's a long story, but I made some mistakes when I was young, and my bloodline got cursed as a result, forcing me to hide in the Lower Heavens since I cannot increase my cultivation above Spirit Grandmaster," Feng Yuxiang gave a brief explanation.

"Anyways, we can talk about my situation later. Most Divine Beasts loath humans, so it would be for the best if you kept that a secret..."

"What made you decide to do that with Brother Yuan?" Xiao Hua suddenly asked.

Lan Yingying then explained her situation to them, everything about the demons, and how she had to continue the legacy.

Sometime later, Feng Yuxiang mumbled, "Since the Young Master agreed to impregnate you, there's a good chance that he might agree to impregnate me if I asked..."

Feng Yuxiang suddenly felt a cold gaze staring at her when she said those words, causing her to turn to look at Xiao Hua, who was glaring at her with dangerous-looking eyes.

"I-I was joking... It was only a joke... You don't have to look at me like that." Feng Yuxiang quickly said with a stiff smile. "I never even thought about having children, and I am still too young to think about those things."

"By the way, how old are you?" Feng Yuxiang then asked Lan Yingying.

"26 years old," she answered.

Feng Yuxiang jumped out of her seat after hearing this, and she exclaimed, "What! Only 26 years old!? You're practically a baby as a Divine Beast! And you already have a baby coming?! Heavens! You're moving too fast!"

"R-Really?" Lan Yingying was also surprised by Feng Yuxiang's reaction.

"Take me for example! I am in my six digits and I don't even dare think about having a child!" Feng Yuxiang said.

"What? You're at least 100,000 years old?" Meixiu was surprised to hear this.

Feng Yuxiang nodded, "123,200 years to be exact, and I would be considered as a 'youth' in the eyes of the older Divine Beasts that have

lived for millions upon millions of years."

"If you make it sound like that, 26 years is really nothing..." Meixiu mumbled.

It was at this moment Zhu Yuying returned with the technique in her hands as well as the manager from the fourth floor.

"Sorry, it took a while." Zhu Yuying then handed the technique to Meixiu in a casual manner.

"Here you go."

"Thank you..." Meixiu accepted the technique.

"Wait... What the hell is going on here?" Fei Xinyi said with a frown on her face.

And she continued, "You came all the way to the fourth floor to grab a technique for someone in the Lower Heavens? Are you crazy? There's no way the Master authorized this!"

"Oh yeah? Wanna make a bet? If you win, I will do whatever you say for the rest of the week. However, if you lose, you will have to listen to me for the rest of the week." Zhu Yuying glared at her with a serious expression.

"Che! This is why I hate you!" Fei Xinyi turned around and quickly stomped away.

There was no way she'd risk it, and she'd rather die than be Zhu Yuying's dog for an entire week.

"I hope the Master finds out about this and punishes you!"

Once Fei Xinyi left, Meixiu asked, "Is everything okay?"

"Don't worry about it, we're always like this."

"Anyways, take a look at the technique. It's a Divine-grade technique specifically for your physique. I hope you like it."

Meixiu looked at the scroll on her grasp and said, "Divine-grade? This is a very expensive item, right? I don't have enough money for it..."

"Hahaha... Don't worry about the money. It's for free. That was my Master's wish as well."

Feng Yuxiang and the others were surprised to hear this.

Just who is the Master of the Myriad of Techniques? He must be ridiculously generous or loaded to give away a Divine-grade technique for free even if he's in the upper heavens.

"I see... Thank you... Again." Meixiu said.

Meanwhile, on the third floor, the guards finally came to a decision.

"Hey, you. You may go up. However, just so you know, if you're lying, death will be the least of your worries!" The guards said to Yuan.

Yuan nodded and proceeded to head upstairs.

Once he reached the door, he opened it and walked into the portal without hesitation.

After the falling sensation, Yuan appeared in the middle of the sky again.

Of course, since he could fly, he wasn't worried at all that he might fall to his death.

Yuan proceeded to fly around until he could see the flying platform from before.

After landing, he started waiting for Senior Bai to make his appearance.

"What a beautiful place... I wonder if there's anything beyond these mountains..." Yuan mumbled to himself as he took the time to watch the

scenery, something he didn't get the chance to do the previous time he was here.

A few minutes later, Yuan could see Senior Bai's figure approaching his location from a distance.

However, he was not alone, and flying beside him was another individual—a beautiful woman who could only be described as a goddess.

When Yuan saw this goddess, his eyes widened with surprise, as she was the same goddess he met during his character evaluation!

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Chapter 430 - Factions

Many minutes before Senior Bai went to meet Yuan and shortly after he'd spoken with Zhu Yuying, Senior Bai was sitting around a large round table with eight other individuals.

"What's the matter, Elder Bai?" One of the individuals there asked him after noticing that he'd suddenly spaced out.

"A little something," he said before turning to look at the goddess sitting at the other side of the table and continuing to speak, "I have been told that 'he' has returned to the Myriad of Techniques."

"He?"

Everyone in the room raised their eyebrows in a puzzled manner.

Even the goddess looked confused, so Senior Bai explained, "Do you remember that talk I had with you not long ago? That I'd met 'him' at my store?"

The goddess immediately stood up from her seat when she realized what Senior Bai was talking about, and this startled the others, as they usually don't see her act in such a manner.

When Senior Bai saw her reaction, he said with a smile, "Should we take a break from the meeting? We've been at it for a while now."

Everybody there turned to look at the goddess.

"Let's take a break," she said.

And she continued, "Elder Bai, I would like to get a breath of fresh air."

"I know just the place." Senior Bai said with a smile on his face.

He then retrieved some sort of device before tossing it on the floor, creating a portal that was shaped like a door.

And without saying anything, the goddess began walking towards the portal, entering it a moment later.

"What is going on, Elder Bai?" The other seven individuals there asked him.

However, he merely shook his head and said, "I don't dare to say it. If you really want to know, ask her yourself."

The people there exchanged looks with each other. Ask the goddess? As curious as they were, none of them wanted to unnecessarily stick their noses in her business, as they might make her angry, and nobody there wanted to see that.

"I will be back." Senior Bai then said to them before entering the portal as well.

The portal closed after Senior Bai entered it.

On the other side of the portal that led them to another dimension, the goddess had been waiting for Senior Bai.

"What took you so long? Let's go," she said to him in a seemingly impatient manner.

Senior Bai smiled and said, "Is this what you look like when you're excited? I don't think I have seen you like this before—" Senior Bai forcefully closed his mouth when he saw the dangerous look the goddess was giving him.

"Let's go," he said with a bittersweet smile before flying to the hovering platform a few minutes away from their location.

Once they got close, they were able to see a masked figure standing on the platform and seemingly admiring the scenery, and he was emitting a profound aura that was similar to dragons.

"Spirit Grandmaster...? Why am I not surprised?" Senior Bai smiled when he saw the powerful aura around Yuan.

However, the goddess behind him remained nonchalant and with a cold expression on her face.

Meanwhile, Yuan was filled with surprise when he saw the goddess, as he didn't expect to see her in this place.

"I didn't expect to see you so soon after our last meeting, Yuan." Senior Bai said to him after they arrived in front of him.

"H-Hello, Senior Bai and..." Yuan didn't know how to address the goddess and waited for her to speak.

"Xu Jiaqi— that is my name," she said.

Yuan nodded and continued, "It's nice to see you again, Miss Xu. I didn't think I'd see you again until I reached the upper heavens."

'Miss Xu...?' Senior Bai raised his eyebrow after hearing this, as he has never heard someone address her so casually.

However, Xu Jiaqi didn't seem to mind and said, "I also didn't expect to see you so soon. So you've only reached Spirit Grandmaster, huh?"

Xu Jiaqi wasn't surprised by his insane progress speed. In fact, she even sounded a little disappointed.

"Are you still in the Lower Heavens?" She suddenly asked him.

"Yes."

"What have you been doing this entire time? If it was anyone else with that physique, they would've been a Spirit King by now. Stop fooling around

and come to the upper heavens already— you're wasting your talents," she continued.

"Eh? But there's no reason for me to rush things. I want to enjoy the cultivation world, and there are still things I must do in the Lower Heavens." Yuan said.

Xu Jiaqi's eyebrows twitched after hearing Yuan's response. It's been a very long time since someone has dared to talk back to her. People would usually just follow her words and won't say anything back.

However, she wasn't angry even in the slightest like she normally would.

"Miss Xu, you seem to know a lot about my physique. Can you tell me more about it?" Yuan suddenly asked her.

After a moment of silence, she spoke, "What do you want to know about it?"

"Anything at all... But I am interested in its origins and what else I can do with this physique. I know that I can consume monster cores and demon cores, but that's about it. And does my physique have a limit?"

Xu Jiaqi narrowed her eyes at Yuan, and she spoke after a moment of silence, "I don't mind telling you, but only if you promise to join my faction once you reach the upper heavens."

"Your faction? What's that? Is it anything like a sect?" Yuan asked.

"Allow me to explain." Senior Bai said, and he continued, "Factions are similar to families, but you follow rules as though it's a sect, so it's something like a mixture of both. Also, there's no real obligation, so you can leave whenever you want."

"A mixture of families and sects? What is the purpose of a faction?" Yuan then asked.

Chapter 431 - Celestial Overlords

"Factions are essential in the upper heavens because without one, you will be vulnerable in a world where the majority of people have a faction. You may think Immortals— even Gods are invincible, but in the upper heavens where there are other Immortals and Gods, nobody is safe." Senior Bai explained to him.

"If you join a powerful faction, unless the other factions want to risk a war, they won't dare to touch you."

"Immortals, Gods, even powerful sects— they all belong to a faction."

"Do you understand the importance of factions now?" Senior Bai asked him.

Yuan nodded, "Yes, I understand."

"Now that you understand what factions are, what is your answer?" Xu Jiaqi asked him again.

"My faction— the Celestial Overlords, is one of the most powerful factions in the entire Nine Heavens with many peak experts and legendary figures. As long as you promise to join us, I will tell you everything I know about the Heaven Refining Physique."

"However, if you refuse, I won't tell you anything, as you could be a potential threat to us in the future. Friend of foe— you choose."

"The Celestial Overlords..." Yuan mumbled in a low voice.

He then turned to look at Senior Bai and asked him, "Are you also part of the Celestial Overlords?"

Senior Bai nodded with a smile on his face.

'If Senior Bai is part of this faction, it should be fine if I join as well since he's a good person. Furthermore, I get to learn more about my physique...'

After pondering for a few moments, Yuan nodded and said, "Okay, I will join the Celestial Overlords."

A subtle smile appeared on Xu Jiaqi's face when she heard Yuan's words, but that smile quickly disappeared, and she said afterward, "Then starting from this point forth, you are a member of the Celestial Overlords!"

Xu Jiaqi suddenly raised her hand and snapped her fingers.

A few seconds later, somewhere in the upper heavens, a large jade tablet began glowing before a complex symbol emerged from the jade tablet.

This symbol disappeared shortly after it emerged from the jade tablet, appearing on Xu Jiaqi's palms the next second.

Xu Jiaqi showed Yuan this golden symbol and said, "This is proof that you're part of the Celestial Overlords. You will be starting at the bottom of the ranks since you just joined. In order to raise your rank, you must contribute to the faction by doing good deeds and making a name for yourself."

"The ranks are as followed from the lowest to the highest— Apprentice, Warrior, Captain, General, Commander, Overlord, and lastly, Celestial Overlord. The higher your rank in the faction, the more authority and benefits you obtain."

"There are also rules you must follow as a member of the faction."

"One, you cannot tarnish or damage our faction's reputation."

"Two, you must listen to those above your rank as long as it's a lawful order."

"Three, you cannot seriously harm or kill a fellow member of the faction."

"And lastly, you cannot betray the faction and its members."

"Of course, there are exceptions, but ultimately, it will be the higher-ups who will determine whether you will be punished or not. If you have any problems, whether it's about another member or something else, you can make an official complaint and we will hear you out. If you wish to leave the faction, you must also speak with someone at least three ranks above you."

"Do you have any questions so far?" Xu Jiaqi asked him afterward.

Yuan shook his head.

"Then accept this symbol if you're ready and you'll officially become a member of the Celestial Overlords."

Xu Jiaqi extended her arms, handing the symbol to Yuan.

Yuan took a deep breath and reached for the golden symbol.

The moment he touched the symbol, it entered his body and disappeared.

Ding!

[You have unlocked Factions!]

[You have joined the Faction: Celestial Overlords!]

[Faction: Celestial Overlords]

[Faction Rank: Apprentice]

"Welcome to the faction, Yuan." Senior Bai said to him with a smile.

"Thank you, Senior Bai."

"If you want to reveal your rank and show proof that you're with the Celestial Overlords for anyone that may ask you in the future, you can do so by doing this—"

Senior Bai flipped his palms, and the symbol 'Overlord' appeared on it.

Yuan followed Senior Bai's movements and flipped his palm while imagining his faction rank showing up.

The symbol 'Apprentice' appeared on his palm a second later.

"If you have any problems with the faction or one of its members, you can contact me through the Myriad of Techniques. There are little to no problems that I cannot solve with my rank. Of course, if anything, there is a Celestial Overlord over here." Senior Bai pointed at Xu Jiaqi with his gaze.

"By the way, this is a privilege that not everyone gets, so don't abuse it."

"I won't." Yuan nodded.

Xu Jiaqi then said, "Now that you're part of the faction, let me tell you about the Heaven Refining Physique— at least everything I know about it."

After taking a deep breath, she said, "The Heaven Refining Physique is a heaven-defying physique that, as you already know, allows you to consume monster cores, demon cores, and resources that normal people would not even dare to think about."

"And as far as I am aware, there have only been two other individuals who had the Heaven Refining Physique before you. Of course, only one person can have this physique at a time, so the other two are most likely dead."

"Two people?" Yuan was surprised to hear this, as he was only aware of one.

Xu Jiaqi nodded and said, "One of them was the founder of the Demon Sealing Clan, and the other was... the founder of the Celestial Overlords..."

"What?" Yuan's eyes widened with surprise.

The person who created the faction Celestial Overlords also had the Heaven Refining Physique? No wonder why Xu Jiaqi wanted him to join her

faction! It turns out that his physique has a history within the faction, and it was a pretty significant one!

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Chapter 432 - Supreme Heaven's Legacy

After revealing that the founder of their faction also had the Heaven Refining Physique. Xu Jiaqi continued to speak, "As you can already guess by now, both of these people that used to have the Heaven Refining Physique had achieved great things in their life, so I am hoping you'd be the same."

Yuan then asked, "What about its limits? I have a few treasures with me that might help me reach Spirit King or above if I consumed them, but I was told that my body would not be able to handle it, as I'd be gaining too much spiritual energy at once."

"There is a limit." Xu Jiaqi said, and she continued, "The Heaven Refining Physique merely allows you to consume things like monster cores and demon cores, but if you consume too much spiritual energy at once, your body will explode just like any other cultivator. It's just that your 'limit' is higher than others, so don't overestimate yourself and consume only what you can endure."

"I-I see..." Yuan mumbled, feeling relieved that he'd listened to Feng Yuxiang's advice and didn't consume the Dragon Ancestor's blood essence.

"Furthermore, once you reach Spirit King, your Heaven Refining Physique will no longer work."

"Wait... what?" Yuan's eyes widened with shock when he heard this.

"I mean, it will still work, but it won't be as effective. This is because you haven't unlocked the full potential of the Heaven Refining Physique. Once

you evolve it, you will be able to consume treasures above Spirit King."

"Heaven Refining Physique's full potential? How do I evolve a physique? I didn't even know that was possible."

Xu Jiaqi shook her head and said, "I don't know. The founder never really gave any details, but he once said that he had to 'evolve' his physique before he could further improve his cultivation past Spirit King."

"The Heaven Refining Physique is an extremely rare and unique physique. There is almost no information out there, but if it's anything like other physiques that can evolve, you'll have to temper your body with some sort of treasure."

"Temper my body... Okay, I will keep that in mind."

"I will try to look through some records to see if the founder had left some clues behind, but I cannot promise you anything." Senior Bai said.

"Thank you." Yuan nodded.

"If you go to the Demon Sealing Clan, they might have some answer since their founder had the same physique, but it's going to be a challenge trying to approach them." Xu Jiaqi suddenly said.

"Though, since you have their founder's physique, maybe it'll be easier for you."

Xu Jiaqi then asked, "Do you have any more questions?"

"Is there anything else I can consume besides monster cores and demon cores?" Yuan then asked.

Xu Jiaqi pondered before speaking, "The founder usually consumes monster cores and demon cores, but I have seen him consume spirit stones at times. Obviously, cultivators don't normally consume spirit stones."

"Spirit stones, huh..."

Sometime later, Xu Jiaqi asked him, "By the way, do you still have my Ancient Spirit Jade?"

"I do... but I don't have it on me. Do you want it back?" Yuan said to her.

"You don't have it on you? Even though I told you to keep it close to you? What if you lose it? That thing isn't cheap, you know. In fact, it's worth more than everything in the Lower Heavens combined." Xu Jiaqi quickly began lecturing him.

"It's okay, my friend is keeping it safe for me. Since she's much stronger than me, it's safer to let her protect it."

"You gave it to somebody?! How can you be so trusting? I highly doubt this 'friend' of yours won't take advantage of your kindness and steal it from you."

"She won't do that. We have been together since the beginning, and I trust her fully."

"Oh really? Who's this friend of yours and what's her background?" Xu Jiaqi suddenly inquired about Xiao Hua.

"Her name is Xiao Hua, but I don't really know her background..."

Xu Jiaqi coldly snorted after hearing this and said, "How can you trust somebody when you don't even know their background? Laughable. And judging from your aura right now, you can kill even a Spirit Lord with some effort. As if there's someone stronger than you in the Lower Heavens."

"It's true. She's a Spirit King."

"Spirit King? How can there possibly be a Spirit King in the Lower Heavens?" Xu Jiaqi frowned.

"I think it has something to do with her Legacy, but she never told me the details. Though, she did tell me that her mission was to bring me to the Supreme Heavens."

"The Supreme Heavens?"

The frown on Xu Jiaqi's face grew deeper, and she spoke after a moment of silence, "The Legacy your friend has... Is it the Supreme Heaven's Legacy?"

"Eh? You know about her Legacy?" Yuan asked with a surprised look on his face.

"Haaa..." Xu Jiaqi suddenly sighed before rubbing her eyes.

Even Senior Bai shook his head with a complicated expression on his face.

"I won't say too much since it's none of my business, but your friend... You should separate yourself from her as soon as possible."

"Eh? Why?" Yuan was baffled by her warning.

"Because she's an 'Exile'." Xu Jiaqi said in a cold voice.

"An exile? What is—"

However, before Yuan could ask about it, he suddenly experienced a sharp pain in his chest.

"Ah!"

Yuan suddenly released a painful cry, startling Senior Bai and Xu Jiaqi.

"Hey! What happened?!" Xu Jiaqi asked him, but Yuan was no longer conscious.

Seeing Yuan's body falling to the ground, Xu Jiaqi subconsciously reacted and went to catch his body.

"Elder Bai!" Xu Jiaqi suddenly shouted his name.

Senior Bai quickly appeared beside her and touched Yuan's forehead with his finger to examine his body.

"He's just unconscious. His body isn't harmed." Senior Bai said a moment later.

"What happened to him?"

"I don't know. Let me examine his condition some more."

While Senior Bai examined his condition, Yuan himself was completely unaware that he was unconscious.

In fact, after experiencing the sudden pain, Yuan found himself in an unfamiliar place, almost like he had been teleported to somewhere.

In this new place, the sky was dark and somewhat red with red lightning striking the ground every second.

Yuan looked around, and to his surprise, even shock, there were bloodied corpses in every direction that piled up like mountains.

It was a horrific sight that would terrify even the most cold-hearted cultivators in the world. However, for some reason, Yuan didn't feel anything when he saw this bloody scene.

"Hm?"

Yuan lifted his arms when he realized that he was holding onto something in his hands.

"What the... Why am I holding this sword?" Yuan was speechless when he realized that he had a sword that was still dripping with blood in his grasp.

Suddenly, a loud roar that caused the place to tremble resounded behind him, causing Yuan to turn around.

When Yuan turned around, he saw a person wearing clothes soaked in blood and a bloodied face flying at him.

Yuan didn't recognize this person, but it was clear to him that this person was trying to harm him.

And without thinking, almost as though his body reacted instinctively, Yuan swung his arm, slicing the man cleanly in half.

The dead man's body fell onto the ground and immediately blended in with the environment that was littered with countless corpses.

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Chapter 433 - Sea Of Corpses And Blood

"Pathetic ants."

A cold voice came from Yuan's mouth after killing the unknown attacker, yet the voice didn't belong to Yuan.

'What is going on?' Yuan wondered inwardly, as his situation was quite bizarre, but this isn't his first time being in this kind of situation, as he would have these dreams every once in a while after he unlocked his bloodline.

However, the only difference was that these dreams would happen in the real world while he slept. This is the first time he's having one of these realistic dreams while playing Cultivation Online.

Furthermore, this dream was vastly different compared to his other dreams. It was much more bloody and more sinister in nature.

"Since this is a dream, does this mean I am actually unconscious right now? What bad timing..." Yuan sighed.

As much as he wanted to wake up from this dream, he knew that it was impossible to wake up by himself, as these dreams would not stop until he experiences all of it.

Sometime later, the person Yuan was dreaming of suddenly flew off the ground and towards the darkened sky.

Yuan looked down at the sea of corpses and blood beneath him, and he wondered what caused this carnage.

'Yuan' continued to fly straight for many hours, and there would be someone attacking him every few minutes.

Of course, these attackers were instantly slain by Yuan before they could even get close.

A few hours later, Yuan stopped after he arrived in front of this floating temple that was the most magnificent building Yuan has ever seen, as it was so grand and luxurious that it made him speechless.

However, right before he reached the doors, even more people surrounded him, and all of them appeared to be extremely powerful people.

Hundreds... thousands... millions of people appeared out of the blue to surround him.

Yuan could see the mouth of these people moving, yet he wasn't able to hear their voices for some reason.

After a few minutes, these people flew at him with their weapons raised.

Yuan closed his eyes and sighed.

When he opened his eyes again, half of the people surrounding him had disappeared, and thousands of lifeless bodies could be seen falling to the ground.

Those that were still alive held terrified expressions on their faces, almost like they were looking at the devil himself.

Suddenly, a bright light appeared in the distance.

This light flew in their direction and stopped a few miles away from Yuan.

The light began disappearing once it stopped moving, revealing a few figures inside.

However, right as Yuan turned to look at these newcomers' faces, his vision turned black, and he could hear familiar voices coming from beside him.

Meanwhile, back at Senior Bai's world, after examining Yuan's body, he said, "There's really nothing wrong with his body, but for some odd reason, his symbol is emitting this aura I have never seen before."

"Aura? Let me see it..." Xu Jiaqi pulled the Celestial Overlords symbol out of Yuan's body to inspect it.

"It's reacting to his body... But even I don't know why it's doing this..." Xu Jiaqi said after a moment of silence.

It was at this moment Yuan began opening his eyes.

Even though he'd spent a couple of hours inside his dream, only a few minutes have passed since he lost consciousness.

"Yuan? Are you okay?" Senior Bai asked him after noticing that he was waking up.

"Yes, I am okay."

"What happened just now?" Xu Jiaqi then asked.

"I don't know. I felt this pain in my body and then I began having this weird dream the next moment," he said after sitting up.

"Don't worry, I have these dreams often."

"Dreams?" Xu Jiaqi raised her eyebrow, yet she didn't think too much of it.

"Anyways, as long as you're okay."

Sometime later, once they were certain Yuan was fine, Xu Jiaqi said, "It's about time we return."

And she continued, "As for the Ancient Spirit Jade... You can keep it. It's a gift for joining the faction."

Yuan nodded, "Thank you for everything. I will try my best to contribute to the faction!"

"I will send you out now. If you need to speak with me, you know where to go." Senior Bai said to Yuan before sending him to the portal.

Once Yuan was gone, Senior Bai smiled and said, "The others will be very jealous if they learn that you'd personally recruited someone, and he's even someone from the Lower Heavens."

However, Xu Jiaqi didn't say anything and merely stood there in silence, seemingly in a daze.

"He reminds me of someone," she suddenly said.

"Hm? Yuan? Who?" Senior Bai asked.

"The founder."

"Eh?" Senior Bai was dumbfounded after hearing this.

"Really? I have never met the founder so I can't really say. What's similar between them? Their demeanor or aura?"

"His eyes." Xu Jiaqi said, and she continued, "The more I look at his eyes, the more I get this feeling."

Sometime later, they returned to the table where the others were.

"You're finally back." One of them said when they saw their return.

"Did something happen?" Senior Bai asked them after noticing the weird atmosphere.

"You didn't feel that just now? Where did the two of you go?" Another one said.

"What happened?" Xu Jiaqi asked them in a solemn voice.

"The entire world shook for a good minute just now."

"What?" Senior Bai's eyes widened.

"The ninth heaven shook?" Xu Jiaqi was also surprised to hear this.

"Yeah. Hopefully, it's nothing to be worried about."

"The last time the ninth heaven shook, the first Celestial Emperor was murdered..." Senior Bai said.

The place turned silent after Senior Bai said such a sentence.

Meanwhile, Yuan returned to the Myriad of Techniques after leaving Senior Bai's world.

When the guards saw him return safely, they both released a sigh of relief, as it meant that they get to keep their job and life.

A few minutes later, Yuan returned to the first floor where everyone was waiting.

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Chapter 434 - Spirit Severing Scripture

"Welcome back, Yuan."

The first person to notice his presence was Zhu Yuying.

"How was your visit with my Master?"

"It went better than I'd expected," he said.

"That's great to hear. Anyways, I gave your friend the perfect cultivation technique, but if you need anything else, just let me know."

"Really? How much will it cost?" Yuan asked, expecting to pay for it.

"My Master said it's for free so you don't have to pay a single gold."

"Free again? I kind of feel bad now." A bittersweet smile appeared on Yuan's face.

"Don't worry about it. My Master has plenty of techniques, and it's only a Divine-rank technique. If he cannot afford to give away techniques, he wouldn't be doing it in the first place."

"Alright." Yuan nodded.

Sometime later, Yuan and the others prepared to leave the Myriad of Techniques.

"See you again next time, Yuan. Though, I will be replaced in a few weeks, so I might not be able to see you until you reach the fifth heaven."

"The fifth heaven?" Yuan asked.

"There are nine heavens, and the place you're at right now is the first heaven, also known as the Lower Heavens."

"I see... But that might take a while."

"It's okay. I can wait." Zhu Yuying said with a bright smile on her face.

A few minutes later, Yuan and the others left the store, and they returned to Long Chen City.

"What are we going to do now, Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang asked him.

"Let's find a place where Meixiu can cultivate in peace," he said.

"Is there a Cultivators' Haven in this city?"

"I think so." Feng Yuxiang nodded.

"Okay, let's go."

Feng Yuxiang and Lan Yingying returned to his body to make traveling more convenient, but Xiao Hua decided to stay with Yuan and Meixiu.

"Are you okay, Brother Yuan?" Xiao Hua asked him when she noticed him staring at her.

"Yes, I am fine." Yuan nodded.

Although Xu Jiaqi warned him about Xiao Hua, even telling him to separate from her, he still trusted her.

'An exile, huh? I never got to ask them about it. Though, it doesn't matter. Xiao Hua is still Xiao Hua no matter what background she has.' Yuan thought to himself.

Sometime later, Yuan asked the pedestrians about the Cultivators' Haven.

Once he had the directions, they began making their way towards the place.

About half an hour later, they arrived before a tall building that looked very familiar to Yuan, as the place resembled the one in Spring City.

"Welcome to Cultivators' Haven! How may I help you today?" A pretty lady asked them from behind the desk.

"I'd like to borrow one room from the highest floor for seven days," Yuan said to her.

"You seem like you've been with us before. Do you have a key?" The worker asked him.

"No, I don't."

"That's okay, we can give you a new one. For seven days, it will cost you 7,000 gold coins."

It was at this moment Yuan realized that he had no money besides the spirit stones given to him by Xi Meili.

"Actually, can you make it 10 days instead of 7? I will pay with a spirit stone. It is worth 10,000 gold, right?"

"Spirit stones? If you pay with spirit stones, you get bonus time, so you'll actually get 15 days instead of 10."

"That sounds great." Yuan nodded and handed one spirit stone to the worker behind the desk.

After accepting the spirit stone, the lady went to the back to prepare his key.

A few minutes later, she returned with the key and handed it to him.

Once they had the key, Yuan went upstairs with the others until they reached the top floor.

"How do I cultivate this technique? I have never cultivated before." Meixiu asked him after they entered the room.

"You basically read whatever is in the technique and recite it until you 'comprehend' the technique. Once you comprehend it, you can practice it and begin absorbing the spiritual energy in the air and cultivate."

"Okay."

Meixiu then took a seat in the middle of the room and opened the scroll in her hands.

"Spirit Severing Scripture? It has the same name as my physique..." Meixiu mumbled.

It was no wonder Zhu Yuying picked this cultivation technique for her, as the technique seemed like it was literally created for her physique.

Meixiu began to read the scripture.

Although the words were foreign and she has never seen them before, Meixiu was able to comprehend the words for some reason and read the scripture without a problem.

And a few minutes later, after reading through the Spirit Severing Scripture just once, a notification appeared before Meixiu.

Ding!

[You have learned Spirit Severing Scripture!]

[Spirit Severing Scripture]

[Rank: Divine]

[Mastery Level: 1]

[Description: Absorbs 5 Qi per second. If used during Spirit Form, you will absorb 50 Qi per second instead.]

Once she learned the cultivation technique, Meixiu closed her eyes and began reciting the technique inside her mind.

Soon, her breathing patterns changed.

[You have cultivated for the first time, unlocking Qi Experience]

[Due to Qi Gathering Array, your Qi absorption rate has increased slight]

[5/5,000]

[12/5,000]

[17/5,000]

[24/5,000]

In just a couple of minutes after Meixiu started cultivating, she reached her first breakthrough.

[You have succeeded in breaking through your mortal shackles, becoming a Spirit Apprentice!]

[Physical Strength, Physical Defense +75]

[Mental Strength, Mental Defense +150]

Name: Meixiu

Cultivation: First Level Spirit Apprentice

Legacy: None

Bloodline: None

Physique: Spirit Severing Physique

Physical Strength: 157

Mental Strength: 1,870

Soul Strength: 555

Physical Defense: 109

Mental Defense: 300

"Wow, she made a breakthrough already? That was faster than I'd expected. This cultivation technique was definitely made for her." Yuan mumbled in a low voice when he saw Meixiu absorbing spiritual energy after a single read and breaking through mere minutes after she started cultivating.

Although she was assisted by the Qi Gathering Array in the Cultivators' Haven, Meixiu still managed to breakthrough faster than Yuan when he first started cultivating.

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Chapter 435 - Meixius Cultivation

Chapter 435 - Meixiu's Cultivation

"Yuan, I had a breakthrough," Meixiu stopped cultivating and said to him with a slightly excited feeling in her chest.

"I noticed. Congratulations on becoming a cultivator." Yuan said with a smile.

"What do I do now?" she then asked.

"You continue to cultivate, I guess."

"When should I stop?"

"Whenever you like or feel like the progress is starting to slow down significantly."

"I understand. I will try to cultivate some more." Meixiu nodded and returned to her cultivation.

"She's probably the most talented person behind Brother Yuan that Xiao Hua has seen in the Lower Heavens... Not including the Divine Beasts." Xiao Hua said sometime after Meixiu continued her cultivation.

"This is the first time I've seen you approve of someone," Yuan said with a smile.

Xiao Hua nodded silently.

About five hours later, Meixiu reached the 4th level Spirit Apprentice.

[You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough]

[You have reached Second Level Spirit Apprentice]

[Physical Strength, Physical Defense +100]

[Mental Strength, Mental Defense +175]

[You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough]

[You have reached Third Level Spirit Apprentice]

[Physical Strength, Physical Defense +125]

[Mental Strength, Mental Defense +200]

[You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough]

[You have reached Fourth Level Spirit Apprentice]

[Physical Strength, Physical Defense +150]

[Mental Strength, Mental Defense +225]

"How long have I been cultivating?" Meixiu asked him after she lost track of time.

"About five hours," Yuan said after he looked at the time left on the key.

"Five hours?" Meixiu was surprised to hear that so much time had passed because it didn't feel that long for her.

"If you want to continue cultivating, I don't mind. We don't really have anything else planned, anyway." Yuan said to her.

Meixiu nodded, "Okay. I will continue to cultivate for some more or until Yu Rou calls us to play, but let me cook dinner first."

"Let's leave this room first before we log off so that we don't waste our limited time," Yuan said.

"See you later, Xiao Hua," Yuan said to her before they logged off the game.

Once they left the game, Meixiu went to prepare for dinner whilst Yuan cultivated in the real world.

After dinner, Meixiu helped Yuan take a quick shower.

Sometime later, Meixiu sat on her bed and tried to cultivate the Spirit Severing Scripture.

However, unlike cultivation online, she was unable to succeed in just a few minutes.

"Yuan, are you awake?" Meixiu knocked on his door after seeing no progress, hoping he'd have some advice for her.

"I'm still up." Yuan's voice resounded a moment later.

"I am having trouble with my cultivation," she said.

"What do you need help with? There's very little I can do to help you in this world, unfortunately."

"I am trying to use the Spirit Severing Scripture, but every time I try to recall it, it's like I cannot remember it," she said.

"Oh, that is probably because you've only just learned the technique today. Try cultivating the technique inside Cultivation Online for a few more days." Yuan advised her.

"Okay."

Meixiu returned to her room shortly after and went back inside Cultivation Online to continue cultivating for the rest of the night.

In the morning, she stopped cultivating to cook breakfast for Yuan.

After breakfast, they both entered the game together.

"I managed to reach the fifth level last night. It's taking much longer to breakthrough with each level." Meixiu said to him.

Although it only took her 5 hours to reach the fourth level, it took her the entire night— 8 hours of straight cultivation to reach the next level.

Of course, her progression was still much faster than most of the players in Cultivation Online at this moment.

"Haha, welcome to cultivation, Meixiu. Once you reach my level, it'll take you days if not weeks to increase even a single level." Yuan laughed.

Xiao Hua looked at him and said, "And if Brother Yuan was an ordinary cultivator, it'd take him a hundred times longer..."

Sometime later, Yuan asked Meixiu, "You're going to continue cultivating, right?"

"Yes."

"Then I'll go check out the restaurants in the meantime unless you want to come as well."

"It's okay. I will stay here to cultivate." Meixiu said.

"Alright. Have fun. I'll be back in a few hours."

Thus, Yuan left the Cultivators' Haven with Xiao Hua while Meixiu stayed behind to cultivate.

"What do you want to eat today, Xiao Hua?" Yuan asked her.

"Anything Brother Yuan wants," she responded almost immediately.

"What about Feng Feng and Yingying? Anything specific that you two would like to eat?" Yuan asked them next.

"All up to you, Young Master."

"It also doesn't matter to me what we eat." Lan Yingying said.

"Okay. Guess I will just look around and see what's available."

Thus, Yuan began walking around the city until he found a decent restaurant.

Once they decided to eat there, Feng Yuxiang and Lan Yingying appeared so they could eat as well.

"W-Welcome to Lotus Gourmet, esteemed guests..."

The receptionist was startled by Feng Yuxiang and Lan Yingying's beauty, not to mention the noble-like aura around Yuan and Xiao Hua.

It was not just the receptionist. Everyone in the store seemingly froze when they noticed their group's presence, almost like they were looking at royalty.

"Four of us," Yuan said to the receptionist.

"R-Right away!"

The receptionist brought them straight to the best table in the restaurant inside a private room.

"I will be here whenever you need me." The receptionist said to them.

Yuan began looking through the menu, but before he could even finish the menu, he placed it down and said, "Let me just get everything on the menu."

"E-Everything?" The receptionist looked at him with wide eyes.

There were at least 200 dishes on the menu, and with only four people in their group, it seemed unlikely that they would be able to finish it.

However, the receptionist didn't say anything and nodded with a smile on his face, "Right away, esteemed guests."

Chapter 436 - I Found Us Something Even Better!

About fifteen minutes after Yuan ordered the entire menu, the workers returned with dishes in their hands.

"Allow me to welcome you all to the Lotus Gourmet once again, esteemed guests. I am the manager of this place. If there's anything you need from us, just let us know."

Although none of the workers there recognized Yuan and the others' identity, it was clear as day that they were important people just by their noble appearance, not to mention their unfathomable aura.

While the workers were not cultivators, the manager was a peak Spirit Apprentice, and he could feel an invisible aura that made him feel like he was lacking air whenever he got close to Yuan's group.

Unbeknownst to him, they were all above Spirit Master. If he'd known that, the manager would probably be speaking on his knees right now.

The moment the dishes were placed on the table, Yuan began moving his hands and mouth.

Xiao Hua and the others were used to Yuan's eating habits by now so they didn't react when they saw him gobbling down the food like a food monster.

The workers, however, had never seen anything like this before and were greatly shocked by the speed at which the food was disappearing from the table.

Not even a minute after the dish was placed on the table, it would be cleared out by Yuan who didn't even need to look at the dish, as he was subconsciously using Divine Sense.

Of course, Yuan made sure to leave some food for the others, and he would eventually slow down his consumption speed.

About half an hour into their meal, Yuan could suddenly hear a small commotion coming from the outside.

"What? You don't have your best room available? Then make it available! Do you know who we are?!" An arrogant voice resounded.

When Yuan heard this voice, his eyebrows raised, as it sounded very familiar for some reason.

A few moments later, Yuan could hear heavy footsteps approaching their private room.

"I don't care who's eating in here right now, scram for me! The Du Family will be eating here now!"

A young man with an arrogant look appeared and forcefully opened the door before walking inside while shouting.

However, when this young man noticed the beauties sitting around the table, he immediately stopped talking and stared at them with a dazed look on his face.

Since Yuan had his back facing the door, the loud young man didn't notice Yuan's presence at first.

It was at this moment Yuan turned around to look at the young man.

Indeed, he was one of the Du Brothers that Yuan had an altercation with shortly after he became a Spirit Warrior.

"Young Master Du Bai, please slow down."

Suddenly, another figure appeared behind him, and it was the Spirit Master that was in charge of protecting the Du Brothers.

"Hm?"

The Spirit Master's gaze subconsciously turned to look at Xiao Hua for some reason, and when he saw her cute and innocent face, he jumped back and said, "W-What are you doing here?!"

"Why are you shouting like that? Who is—"

It was at this moment Du Bai snapped out of his daze and turned to look at Xiao Hua and Yuan.

"Y-You're that bastard from the auction house! What are you doing here?!" Du Bai finally recognized Yuan.

"As you can see, I am eating here— at least I was until you came barging in here. What do you want?" Yuan said to him with a frown on his face.

Did he not learn his lesson from their previous confrontation?

Du Bai suddenly pointed at Yuan and laughed with an ugly smile on his face.

"Hahaha! I have been looking everywhere for you, you damn bastard! Did you think I would forget about you or that humiliation I experienced on that day?! Not a chance! My parents will be here any minute now, and when they do, I will make you regret ever being born!"

Then Du Bai pointed at Feng Yuxiang and Lan Yingying, "I don't know who you are but you should follow me starting today instead of this loser! My Du Family is a top family in the Lower Heavens! My parents are also Spirit Masters!"

"The Du Family, huh?" Feng Yuxiang mumbled in a nonchalant manner.

A moment later, Du Hai, Du Bai's brother, entered the restaurant alongside a pair of couples and two other families and their children.

"Du Hai! Come look at what we have here!" Du Bai shouted to him.

"What is it? I know you want to reserve the seats, but did you have to run all the way here?" Du Hai sighed as he approached the private room.

His eyes widened when he saw Yuan's handsome face.

"It's you!"

"Are you two looking for a beating again?" Yuan said to them after wiping his hands and mouth with a wet cloth.

"Hahaha! Beat us? I would love to see you try!"

The Du Brothers stood there with their chest proudly puffed.

"What's going on here? Where are our seats, Du Bai?" A middle-aged man suddenly approached them from behind, and the others soon followed.

"Father! I found us something even better! Do you remember that time we went to an auction house and returned with a bruised body? This is the bastard that assaulted us on that day! We finally found him!" Du Bai ran to his father before pointing at Yuan.

"What?" The Du Brother's father and the others there turned to look at Yuan and his table.

However, their eyes didn't linger on Yuan for more than a second because something else had caught their attention—the beautiful young woman sitting across from Yuan.

"M-Madam Feng?! W-What are you doing here?!" The middle-aged man exclaimed in a shocked voice when he saw Feng Yuxiang sitting there with a frown on her face.

"Du Wei, you dare come in here and question me when your children disturbed my peace and even worse—insulted my Young Master? Are you looking to die today?" Feng Yuxiang said to him in a cold voice before

standing up and glaring at them in an oppressive manner, sending shivers down their spine.

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Chapter 437 - Decisive Action

Du Wei, the head of the Du Family and also the Du Brothers' father, was shocked speechless after hearing Feng Yuxiang's words, but he still hasn't been able to comprehend the situation because everything had happened too fast.

How did his children offend Madam Feng, the number one expert in Phoenix City? And more importantly, who is this Young Master that Feng Yuxiang was talking about? This is the first time he has heard of Feng Yuxiang addressing someone in such a respectful manner.

Meanwhile, the other 2 families that had followed the Du Family to this restaurant were already regretting their decision, as they were potentially in jeopardy because of the Du Family.

"What the hell is going on here, Du Wei? I thought you brought us here for a business meeting! If you're doing this to purposefully damage our family's reputation, this means war!" One of them said to him.

"W-Wait! I also don't know what's going on here! Du Bai! Du Hai! Explain yourselves!" Du Wei immediately turned to his sons for answers.

However, the Du Brothers didn't know of Madam Feng or why their father was angry at them.

"What? We didn't do anything! He's the one who's wrong! He's the one we have been looking for! That person who insulted our Du Family and assaulted us! You said that you'd take care of him once we find him!" Du Bai said as he pointed at Yuan.

Du Wei turned to look at Yuan, who was emitting the aura of a Spirit Grandmaster, his heart trembling with shock and disbelief.

A Spirit Grandmaster had assaulted the Du Brothers? If that was the case, they wouldn't even be alive! Furthermore, he didn't even recognize this Spirit Grandmaster!

"You told me that he was a Spirit Warrior! And that he'd attacked you only because you were from the Du Family! You mentioned nothing about a Spirit Grandmaster! As if a Spirit Grandmaster would go out of his way to bully you idiots if you didn't do anything wrong in the first place!" Du Wei shouted at them, feeling a headache coming.

"What? Spirit Grandmaster?" The Du Brothers were shocked upon hearing this.

They were certain that Yuan was a Spirit Warrior when they fought. How did he suddenly become a Spirit Grandmaster in such a short time when they have only managed to increase their own cultivation base by a single level?

"Regardless of what happened between my Young Master and your children in the past, it's clear who's in the wrong right now. We were having a peaceful meal, yet they came in here barking like wild dogs, disturbing our peace. Even worse, he'd insulted my Young Master while telling me to follow him like some kind of servant. Is the Du Family asking me, Feng Yuxiang, to lower my head and become a servant of the Du Family?" Feng Yuxiang asked him in a cold voice.

"T-The Du Family does not dare!" Du Wei quickly said.

Then he turned to look at his sons with an enraged expression.

"Get on your knees and apologize to Madam Feng and everyone here! I will personally take care of you two once we get back to the house!"

"W-What? But—"

Du Bai wanted to say that this wasn't his fault, but before he could even speak, Du Wei flicked his arm and slapped Du Bai in the face.

"Get on your knees and apologize!" Du Wei repeated.

Du Bai laid on the floor with disbelief on his face. This is the first time his father had hit him.

When Du Hai saw his brother getting hit, he knew this was serious and he quickly kneeled on the ground before Yuan and the others.

"I apologize for everything. Please forgive me."

Du Bai followed his brother a moment later and kneeled beside Du Hai.

"I apologize." Du Bai spoke in a forceful voice, clearly unwilling to apologize.

However, when Du Wei saw this, he suddenly extended his arms with an open palm, striking Du Bai in the back the next moment.

"Ah!"

Du Bai released a painful cry before coughing up a mouthful of blood, feeling the cultivation inside his Dantian escaping his body.

In a single and decisive strike, Du Wei had crippled his own son's cultivation.

"Du Bai!" Du Hai was shocked when he saw this, and he turned to look at his father with a fearful look on his face.

"F-Father... you..." Du Bai also stared at him in shock.

Du Wei ignored them and turned to look at Feng Yuxiang before bowing to her.

"If that wasn't enough, I am willing to kill him. Please, spare the Du Family, Madam Feng."

"Uhh..."

Feng Yuxiang was not really that surprised by Du Wei's actions. If this was before she began following Yuan, she might have even wanted Du Bai's head. However, now that she's following Yuan, and knowing his character, she knew that he wouldn't let her kill the Du Brothers.

Thus, she turned to look at Yuan, who was standing there silently, clearly surprised by what had just occurred. Everything had happened so fast, and it ended before he could even react.

Yuan said after a moment of silence, "There's no need to kill him. You have already done enough."

Although he didn't show it on his face, Yuan was pretty appalled that Du Wei would go to such lengths to please another individual. He couldn't comprehend the idea of killing one's own son to make an apology.

"My Young Master has spoken! You can now stop bothering us and scram!" Feng Yuxiang then said.

"Thank you for your mercy, Madam Feng and Young Master." Du Wei bowed to them again before turning to look at the Spirit Master working for their family.

"Pick up the trash and let's go!"

After saying that, Du Wei left the restaurant with the others whilst the Spirit Master carried the Du Brothers away like previously.

"I deeply apologize for that just now, esteemed guests. We'll clean up the place immediately." The manager said to them.

A worker came to clean the blood from the floor a few moments later.

Once the room was clean again, the manager and the other workers left the room, leaving Yuan and the others alone.

Chapter 438 - The Right Choice

"I think I've lost my appetite..." Yuan sighed a few minutes after the Du Family left the scene.

"What's the matter, Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang asked him even though she had an idea.

"I cannot understand why he did that... Did he really have to cripple his own son to make an apology? He was even prepared to kill his own son!"

After a moment of silence, Feng Yuxiang opened her mouth and said, "Because he had to make a choice— his own son or his entire family."

"The cultivation world is a place where one can have their entire family destroyed because a mere servant had offended someone they couldn't afford to offend. In Du Wei's mind, his family was in jeopardy because of his son's action. Therefore, in order to get rid of the problem, he decided to get rid of the one who caused the trouble in the first place."

"This is a very common thing in the cultivation world, Young Master. You shouldn't think too much about it. There are people out there who would be willing to take even their own life in order to please someone."

Before Yuan could even respond to Feng Yuxiang, almost as though she could read his mind, Xiao Hua said, "Brother Yuan, there are unreasonable people out there who would go to the extreme and slaughter an entire family because they didn't like the way a person looked at them. The upper heavens are filled with people like that."

Yuan closed his mouth after hearing Xiao Hua's words, as he was going to ask why someone would destroy an entire family over something so minor.

"In my opinion, what Du Wei did was the right choice. He knew that he couldn't offend me, much less an unknown Spirit Grandmaster like you. Forget about me, the Young Master can destroy the entire Du Family with his current prowess." Feng Yuxiang said.

"But I wouldn't do something like that."

"Of course. We know the Young Master is a benevolent being. However, Du Wei didn't know that, and he wasn't going to risk his entire family just to find out."

And she continued, "The Du Family is a top family in the Lower Heavens for a reason. They know how to survive. In fact, every top family in the Nine Heavens must first learn to survive. If they cannot do that, they would've long been destroyed."

"I understand." Yuan nodded.

Sometime later, they decided to leave the restaurant.

When Yuan tried to pay the bill, the manager politely refused their money and said that it was on the house. After learning that there were Spirit Grandmasters amongst them, the manager no longer dared to accept their money.

After leaving the restaurant, Yuan wasn't sure what he should do, as he'd planned on eating at more than one restaurant before returning to Meixiu.

However, with his appetite ruined, his plans also had to change.

After pondering for some time, Yuan turned to look at Feng Yuxiang and said to her, "Feng Feng, can you train with me for a bit?"

"Train? With the Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang expressed surprise.

He nodded and said, "I have been using the movement technique you taught me for a while now, but I realized that I could only use it properly on the ground. In the air, I am very vulnerable. And I feel like working out a little after eating so much food."

After what he experienced in the Shadow Realm, Yuan realized that he was having trouble dodging attacks while in the air.

Feng Yuxiang chuckled and said, "Young Master, the movement technique is actually much more powerful when used in the air. After all, it's a technique meant for phoenixes. It's just that you haven't reached that level yet, so you can only use it on the ground."

"Let me see where you're at right now with the technique first."

Yuan nodded, and they proceeded to leave the city to find an empty area out in the wild where they can practice freely.

It took about ten minutes before they found the perfect spot.

"Alright, Young Master, I am going to attack you and you're going to dodge it with the movement technique. I will start slow. Let me know when you're ready." Feng Yuxiang picked up a random stick on the ground and treated it like a sword.

Yuan took a deep breath before nodding his head.

"I am ready."

"Here I come!"

Feng Yuxiang kicked her feet and instantly closed their distance, then she swung the wooden stick in her grasp as though it was a sword.

Yuan was surprised by Feng Yuxiang's speed at first, but he was able to dodge her strike perfectly.

However, Feng Yuxiang didn't stop after the first strike and continued to attack him with the wooden stick, increasing her speed and making more complex movements as time went on.

Xiao Hua and Lan Yingying watched them practice in the distance as spectators.

Although Xiao Hua didn't show any reactions, Lan Yingying was greatly impressed by their practice, as this is her first time witnessing such intensive sparring.

Of course, the one who was most surprised there was Feng Yuxiang.

'Heavens... How long has it been since he learned the movement technique? It took me years of practice to reach this stage, yet it's only been a couple of weeks since he learned the technique! Furthermore, he probably achieved all of this while he was inside the Mystic Realm because I have yet to see him practice this technique while I am with him!'

It took less than a minute before Feng Yuxiang realized how much Yuan had progressed with the technique, and she thought to herself, 'How interesting! Let me experience your talents firsthand, Young Master!'

A smile suddenly appeared on Feng Yuxiang's beautiful face, and her movement speed doubled the next moment.

"Whoa!"

Feng Yuxiang's sudden increase in speed caught Yuan off guard, allowing her to connect a hit on his body, but Yuan quickly adjusted himself and continued to dodge the next few attacks.

However, Yuan was no longer dodging Feng Yuxiang's attacks with ease, and he quickly began to sweat.

'Feng Feng... She's strong!' Yuan cried inwardly.

Chapter 439 - Training With Feng Yuxiang

"Haaa... haaa... haaa..."

Yuan laid on the soft ground with his body covered in sweat while panting in an exhausted manner.

They have only been training for about half an hour, but Yuan was already at his limit, feeling even more exhausted than when he fought many experts continuously at the Ancient Dragon City.

Towards the end of their practice, Yuan was getting hit so often that Feng Yuxiang was practically landing every single hit on him, and even though Yuan made improvements to this movement technique, it was still not nearly enough to avoid Feng Yuxiang who was always a step ahead of him.

"Are you finished already, Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang asked him with a completely calm appearance and not a single drop of sweat on her body, looking like she just took a stroll in the park.

"Feng Feng, you're stronger than I thought," Yuan said to her.

"Thank you for the compliment, Young Master. Even with my cultivation suppressed, my techniques are as sharp as ever," she said.

"We should have a serious spar in the future, Feng Feng. Even though training with you is fun, it's not satisfying enough." Yuan said as he sat up after resting enough.

"Hehe... If you want to fight me, you should improve your movement technique even more, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang chuckled.

"Anyways, you have exceeded my expectations in terms of your progression with the movement technique. At this rate, you'll probably be able to start using the movement technique in the air in a few months. By the way, it took me a few hundred years to reach that level and many thousand more to master it."

"I look forward to that day." Yuan nodded.

Feng Yuxiang then said, "I also noticed something else during our training. Young Master, you may be incredibly talented, learning everything at a rapid rate, but you still lack experience. Although your execution with the techniques is flawless, you're still amateurish in terms of actual combat, and that is not something you can easily learn even with your talents."

"Furthermore, the Young Master is used to one-shotting all of his opponents, so you're actually very weak in extended fights."

"What do you suggest, Feng Feng?" Yuan asked her, as he agreed with everything she'd just said.

"That's simple. We can spar with each other, and you don't have to worry about defeating me with a single hit, so you can somewhat go all out. Just don't use your Dragon's Gaze or that suppressing domain since that's basically cheating." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Of course, that is not to say you shouldn't use it during actual combat since it would be for the best if you finished the fight as soon as possible. However, for practice purposes, let's not use it."

"Okay." Yuan nodded.

Yuan proceeded to spend the next hour recovering his energy.

Once he was prepared to move again, Yuan and Feng Yuxiang continued to practice with each other.

However, this time, Feng Yuxiang allowed Yuan to use his weapon, and Feng Yuxiang also retrieved a weapon of her own.

Feng Yuxiang waved around the red sword in her hand casually and asked him, "Are you ready, Young Master?"

"Yes."

The moment Yuan nodded his head, Feng Yuxiang approached him and began attacking him with the sword.

Yuan immediately used the Empyrean Overlord to block the attack, but Feng Yuxiang's strike suddenly changed directions and avoided his sword, almost like she'd anticipated it.

Yuan was surprised and subconsciously used the movement technique to dodge her strike, barely avoiding it.

"Your reaction is quite admirable, but if you had more experience, you would've been able to block that attack without needing to avoid it with your body." Feng Yuxiang said as she sent the next attack.

Once again, right as her sword was about to touch Yuan's blade, it seemingly disappeared from its location before appearing on the other side and flying straight at Yuan's neck.

This time, Yuan managed to react properly and went to block it with the Empyrean Overlord.

However, Feng Yuxiang's sword disappeared for a second time, and by the time Yuan realized this, it was already kissing his neck.

Yuan swallowed nervously when he realized that he would've died if Feng Yuxiang didn't stop her attack at the last moment.

"Young Master, there are some things you cannot overcome with pure strength. Before an experienced cultivator, you may not be at an advantage even if you have a higher cultivation base." Feng Yuxiang said to him as she retrieved the sword from his neck.

Yuan was speechless.

This is the first time he's felt so powerless before someone. Even though it was a spar and he wasn't using his full strength, that was the same for Feng Yuxiang.

After giving Yuan some time to prepare himself again, Feng Yuxiang began attacking him again.

Ding! Ding! Ding!

Feng Yuxiang didn't use her disappearing sword strikes without stopping and would purposefully let Yuan block her attacks at times, but whenever she would see an opening, she would use that to her advantage and corner Yuan in a decisive moment.

In just ten minutes of practice, Feng Yuxiang had 'killed' Yuan over a dozen times.

"Are you ready to give up yet, Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang asked him with a somewhat smug look on her beautiful face.

"N-Not yet! Let's keep going!" Yuan wiped the sweat off his face and prepared himself again.

"That's what I like to hear!"

Yuan was so absorbed in his training with Feng Yuxiang that he'd completely forgotten about Meixiu. However, Meixiu was also absorbed in her cultivation, and they both missed dinner without even realizing it until it was already morning the next day.

"Oh! I completely forgot to log off!" Yuan panicked when he realized this, as it hasn't been long since his last mistake.

Thus, Yuan logged off on the spot.

However, when he realized that Meixiu also hadn't logged off, he returned to the game and then to the Cultivators' Haven with the others.

Chapter 440 - Fierce Beauty

After returning to the Cultivators' Haven, Yuan went straight to the top floor to see if Meixiu was still cultivating, and just as he'd expected, the door to her cultivation room was still closed shut.

Although he wanted to go inside to make sure, he didn't have the key, as it was inside the room with Meixiu.

"I probably shouldn't disturb Meixiu if she's still cultivating, right?" Yuan asked Xiao Hua.

She nodded and said, "That would be very dangerous, as disturbing someone that's absorbed in cultivation could be harmful. There are even cases where some cultivators have been crippled after being disturbed during their breakthroughs. This is why cultivators must find a secure and peaceful place before they begin their cultivation."

"Crippled? That's definitely not good. I guess we can only wait outside until she's done." Yuan said as he took a seat directly in front of the door to Meixiu's room.

Unbeknownst to them, inside the room, Meixiu was actually experiencing enlightenment, hence why she became oblivious to the time.

In the blink of an eye, two days have passed since Meixiu entered the Cultivators' Haven.

"She's taking longer than I'd expected... It's already been two days. I hope she's fine inside." Yuan sighed, and he wondered inwardly, 'Is this what Meixiu felt when I didn't come out of the game for three whole days? Now that I have experienced it for myself, it certainly doesn't feel good, and I don't blame her for worrying.'

"If Brother Yuan is that worried, why don't you take a look inside with your Divine Sense?" Xiao Hua said to him in a calm voice, clearly aware of what was happening inside the room.

"Oh, right! I forgot I could do that!"

Yuan immediately closed his eyes and activated his Divine Sense that penetrated the door and walls in the Cultivators' Haven.

"Oh, I can see Meixiu. She looks fine to me." Yuan released a sigh of relief after seeing that she was perfectly fine inside.

"Wait, what's this weird aura around her? It feels familiar." Yuan suddenly noticed the unfathomable aura around Meixiu.

"She is currently experiencing enlightenment," said Xiao Hua.

"Enlightenment? No wonder..." Yuan mumbled.

Now that he found out the reason for Meixiu's delay, Yuan no longer needed to use his Divine Sense. However, right as he prepared to retract his Divine Sense, for some reason, he looked inside the other two rooms that were occupied by someone else.

One of them was a middle-aged man who emitted the aura of a peak Spirit Warrior.

The other person was a young lady with a fairly unique appearance. Long hair that touched the ground, and a golden color made it look as though her silky hair was silk made of gold. Furthermore, she was wearing a pair of luxurious-looking robes, making it seem like she was royalty.

However, what Yuan found the most interesting about this young lady was her cultivation base—or her lack of cultivation base.

Despite being a Spirit Grandmaster, he was unable to see this young girl's cultivation base, and she looked to be around his age.

Unless this young lady had a much higher cultivation base than him, which was unlikely, Yuan couldn't figure out why he couldn't see her cultivation base.

"Xiao Hua, how come I cannot see that girl's cultivation base?" He decided to ask the expert.

Surely, a Spirit King like Xiao Hua would be able to see her cultivation base, right?

Xiao Hua used her Divine Sense to look at the person Yuan was talking about for a moment before speaking, "That girl is using a cultivation technique to hide her cultivation base, and it's a fairly powerful one because even Xiao Hua cannot see her cultivation base."

"Even you cannot see her cultivation base?" Yuan was more surprised than Xiao Hua herself, and he wondered whether this young lady was an NPC or a player like him.

Suddenly, the mysterious young girl opened her eyelids, revealing a beautiful pair of azure-colored eyes, and she looked to the ceiling with a deep frown on her face, seemingly unhappy about something.

She then stood up and proceeded to leave the room in heavy and angry steps.

Once she was outside, she turned to look at Yuan before pointing at him and shouting, "Hey! I am trying to cultivate here! How dare you peek at me while I cultivate?! Did your parents not teach you any manners?!"

"Uhh..."

Yuan was speechless when this fierce-looking beauty suddenly started yelling at him.

"You're lucky I wasn't having a breakthrough, or I would've smashed your face in by now!" The fierce beauty continued.

"I-I apologize for peeking at you. My curiosity got the better of me." Yuan quickly said to her, as he recognized that he was wrong in this situation.

"What a rude kid—"

The fierce lady suddenly stopped in the middle of her sentence, and her eyes widened in a surprised manner.

"Now that I look at you closely, why are you emitting the aura of a dragon? Are you a dragon?" The fierce beauty suddenly asked him.

"No, I am not." Yuan shook his head.

"Then why... Forget it. If you dare peek at me again, I will smash your skull." The fierce beauty said to him before returning to her room and closing it shut.

"I have never seen anyone as fierce as her before..." Yuan mumbled after she left.

Feng Yuxiang's voice suddenly resounded, "Young Master, that young lady... she's from one of the Four Ancient Families."

"What? Really? How can you tell?" Yuan asked her.

"Her clothes. I have met with people from the Four Ancient Families before, so I know a little about them, and judging by that young lady's clothes, she belongs to the Azure Dragon Family." Feng Yuxiang explained.

"Azure Dragon Family? Are they anything like the dragons in the Ancient Dragon City?" Yuan asked, his interest piqued.

"Well... I don't know anything about the Ancient Dragon City, but judging by what you told us about them, they should be real dragons. The Azure Dragon Family, however, are not really dragons. Instead, they are half-dragons." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Half-dragons? What's the difference?" Yuan continued to ask.

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Chapter 441 - Four Ancient Families

"Someone who is a half-dragon is usually a human with dragon blood mixed within their blood. They're not really dragons, but they have the power of dragons." Feng Yuxiang explained to him.

"I see... That explains her unique appearance. A half-dragon, huh? Does this mean there are also half-phoenixes and half-serpents out there as well?" Yuan then asked.

"That's correct." Feng Yuxiang said.

"By the way, you said the Four Ancient Families, right? I remember hearing about them at the Dragon Essence Temple. How do they differ from the Seven Legacy Families?" Yuan continued to ask, as he found these powerful families that have existed for thousands of years to be very interesting.

"Yes, they're similar to the Seven Legacy Families in the way that they're only branches of the main family somewhere in the upper heavens. However, compared to the Seven Legacy Families, the Four Ancient Families are far superior in terms of prowess and influence in the Nine Heavens."

"While the Seven Legacy Families would have at most two or three Spirit Grandmasters in each family, the Four Ancient Families have at least 7 Spirit Grandmasters in each family. Furthermore, they have much more resources than the Seven Legacy Families."

"However, unlike the Seven Legacy Families that enjoy being in the spotlight, the Four Ancient Families are very secluded and private. They won't make an appearance unless absolutely necessary."

"Then what is someone from the Four Ancient Families doing in this place?" Yuan then asked.

"She's probably doing her trial."

"Trial?"

"Members of the Four Ancient Families are required to leave the family after they reach a certain age to go on a trial. The trial differs from person to person, but if they are unable to pass the trial in 10 years, they are forced to leave the family, and their cultivation will be crippled before they leave. However, if they pass the trial, they will be allowed to ascend to the next world."

"Crippled and forced to leave the family if they fail the trial? That's even stricter than the Seven Legacy Families..." Yuan was speechless upon hearing this, and he wondered why there are so many families like this in the cultivation world.

It was at this moment the door behind him suddenly opened, and Meixiu came running outside in a panicked manner.

"Yuan?!"

Meixiu didn't expect Yuan to be sitting right in front of the door and fell on top of him.

"Are you okay?" Yuan said to her who was on top of him, and he could feel two round and soft sensations pressing against his body.

Meixiu quickly got off his body and stood up with a flushed face.

"Looks like you're finally done with your cultivation. It's been two days, you know?" Yuan said to her in a calm manner.

"I-I am so sorry! I don't know what happened, but it didn't feel that long when I was cultivating! I thought only a couple of hours had passed at most!" Meixiu's habits as a servant kicked in, causing her to lower her body until she was bowing to Yuan.

"It's okay, Meixiu. What you experienced is called enlightenment. You easily lose track of time when you're in that state, so I don't blame you. It also happened to me before, so we can call it even with this." Yuan said with a smile on his face.

When Meixiu got out of her enlightenment and saw how much time she had left in the room, she almost thought that she was dreaming, so she logged off to see the time, and sure enough, two whole days have passed since she started cultivating.

In other words, she didn't cook food for two straight days, leaving Yuan to starve.

This is definitely the biggest blunder she has made in her entire life thus far.

Sometime later, they logged off once Meixiu calmed down.

After cooking the meal, she went to Yuan's room whilst still feeling guilty.

"I'm sorry, Yuan..." She apologized to him again as she fed him the food.

"Don't worry about it," Yuan said.

"Cultivation... It's dangerous... Especially if this happens again..." Meixiu sighed in a worried voice.

"I don't think you have to worry about that since enlightenment doesn't happen often. I heard that some people even live their whole life without experiencing enlightenment a single time, and those who have already experienced enlightenment most likely won't experience it again." Yuan explained to her.

"Is that so..." Meixiu was relieved to hear this.

"What cultivation are you now after two whole days of cultivation?" Yuan asked her a moment later.

"Ninth level Spirit Apprentice," she said.

"Peak Spirit Apprentice already?" Yuan was surprised by her progress.

"Are you going to try cultivating in the real world now? You might be able to do it since you have plenty of experience now."

"I will try later."

And she continued, "By the way, how do you improve Soul Strength?"

"Soul Strength? Doesn't it increase as you improve your cultivation?" Yuan said, as he would get Soul Strength alongside other stats every time he had a breakthrough.

"Although the other stats have improved, my Soul Strength hasn't increased since I started cultivation, and I was just wondering if it requires a special method to train that," Meixiu said.

"Well... I know that you can improve your Soul Strength with Soul Techniques and treasures, but I'm not sure why your Soul Strength isn't increasing. Maybe it has something to do with your physique? We can ask Xiao Hua and the others tomorrow."

"Okay."

Sometime later, after they finished their meal, Meixiu went to her room and tried to cultivate.

As for Yuan, he also started cultivating.

Inside her room, Meixiu sat in the lotus position on the floor since the bed was soft and uneven, and she was used to cultivating on a hard surface.

After taking a deep breath and clearing her mind, Meixiu began reciting the Spirit Severing Technique inside her head, and to her surprise, she was able

to remember the technique very easily, unlike previously when she couldn't even recall the technique no matter how much she tried.

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Chapter 442 - Increase In Crime And Violence

When Meixiu began cultivating, a small wind picked up in her room despite the closed window, and it swirled around her as though it was trying to communicate with her.

About an hour later, Meixiu felt a refreshing sensation spread throughout her body, almost as though she just took a cool bath on a burning day.

It felt just like when she first became a cultivator in Cultivation Online, but it also felt much more intense.

"I am a cultivator now?" Meixiu looked at her own hands.

Besides feeling more energetic than before, there wasn't much change to her body.

Meixiu stood up before taking out some dumbbells from underneath her bed.

Because she has to carry Yuan whenever he needs to leave the bed or go somewhere, Meixiu has to keep herself in shape so that she would be able to lift Yuan without any trouble. Not to mention that it was also physically taxing to be a servant of the Yu Family.

Meixiu began picking up the weights to test her new profound strength, and to her surprise, she could barely feel the weight of the dumbbells, almost like she was picking up feathers.

"Even the 20kg dumbbell feels as light as a broom." Meixiu tossed the dumbbell in the air as though it was nothing.

Meixiu felt the urge to tell Yuan that she'd succeeded in her cultivation and became a cultivator, but she didn't want to disturb him, so she decided to wait until tomorrow during breakfast.

Sometime later, Meixiu returned to sitting on the floor and continued to cultivate some more.

Although it took her only a couple of hours to breakthrough multiple times in Cultivation Online, that was not the case in the real world.

Perhaps it was due to a lack of spiritual energy in the air, or perhaps it's because the cultivation techniques are not as effective in the real world, but it was clear that she would not be able to replicate her cultivation speed in Cultivation Online in the real world.

The following morning, Meixiu revealed to Yuan about her breakthrough during breakfast.

"Really? Congratulations, Meixiu! It had taken me a couple of weeks before I could become a cultivator, so you're already ahead of me in that sense." Yuan said to her.

"Thank you."

"What are you going to do now, Meixiu?" Yuan asked her.

"I'm going to spend a couple of days cultivating in the real world to catch up with everyone," she said.

And she continued, "I just saw the news. There has been a rise in crimes and violence ever since the world learned that cultivation is real. It would be dangerous if I go out there without being prepared."

"What? A rise in crimes and violence? That doesn't sound good at all. What's happening out there?" Yuan asked.

"Too many things, to be honest." Meixiu sighed.

"The most notable change would be how the government plans on dealing with cultivation and cultivators. With the existence of cultivators, the government has decided to step in to regulate it. If you become a cultivator, you will have to register as a cultivator in some database. We don't have to worry about that for now since they are still preparing for it, but it will soon become a law that all cultivators must register as one or they'll be fined or even jailed, as the government wants to keep track of the number of cultivators in the world."

"They also plan on making sure that only qualified people are able to cultivate because they don't want some people to have too much power, especially the bad people. It's only been a couple of days since people started cultivating and violence has already gone up by a lot. One can only imagine what will happen a month from now when there are even more cultivators."

"I see... It makes sense to regulate cultivation since it would definitely be bad if the violent and unreasonable ones become cultivators and start abusing their power. I have already experienced this in Cultivation Online, and it's not a pleasant experience." Yuan said.

"It's impossible for the government to stop everyone from cultivating since Cultivation Online is already widespread with billions of active players. It's not like they can stop everyone from playing the game, either." Meixiu then said.

"Anything else besides the government regulating cultivation?" Yuan asked a moment later.

"Yes. This may come as a surprise, but there are already people creating cultivation schools that are dedicated to people who wish to study cultivation or become a cultivator," she said.

"What? Cultivation schools? Like sects?" Yuan was speechless.

It hasn't been long since people started cultivating and there are already people creating sects?

"Yes, and the schools will provide cultivation techniques to all students. Of course, it won't be for free."

"Hmm... That's interesting..." Yuan said.

"Interesting? You're interested in these cultivation schools?" Meixiu asked him.

"Of course. I wonder how they'll differ from the sects in Cultivation Online."

A few moments later, Meixiu continued, "Oh, influential families around the world are also recruiting talented cultivators. They are not only giving away a large amount of money, but they also promise those who join Earth-rank cultivation techniques. Some are even offering Heaven-rank cultivation techniques."

"Not only schools but even other families are recruiting cultivators? The world adapted to cultivation quicker than I'd expected." Yuan mumbled, and he wondered if the Yu Family was also recruiting cultivators.

Sometime later, Meixiu returned to her own room whilst Yuan returned to Cultivation Online.

However, Yuan didn't stay inside the game for long, as he only went inside to let Xiao Hua and the others know that he won't be returning for a while.

After all, even if they are NPCs, Yuan didn't want them to worry about him if he doesn't show up for a few days or even weeks so that he could focus on cultivation in the real world.

"The world is changing much quicker than I'd initially thought. I must also quickly recover so that I can be there for Yu Rou and Meixiu if anything ever happens to them..."

With this in mind, Yuan took a deep breath and began absorbing the spiritual energy in the world.

Chapter 443 - The Future Of The Yu Family

After eating dinner and brushing her teeth, Yu Rou returned to her own room to spend the rest of the night cultivating.

The following morning, right before sunrise, Yu Rou experienced a breakthrough in her cultivation, reaching 2nd level Spirit Apprentice.

"I haven't slept for a few days now, yet I don't even feel tired or sleepy. Cultivation is such a miraculous thing." Yu Rou sighed to herself afterward.

"I wonder how Meixiu and brother are doing. They should be awake now for breakfast."

Yu Rou decided to call them on her phone.

"Hello?" Meixiu answered the phone after three rings.

"How's it going, Meixiu? Have you started cultivating yet? I just reached the 2nd level, but it took longer than I'd expected— at least compared to Cultivation Online."

"Yes, I have also started to cultivate a few days ago." Meixiu's voice resounded from the phone.

"Really? Congratulations!" Yu Rou said.

And she asked, "Also, you're with Brother Tian in Cultivation Online, right? What are you two doing right now?"

"We have decided to take a break from Cultivation Online to focus on cultivation in the real world," Meixiu said.

"Eh? Really?"

"Yes. With the increased crime and violence because of the cultivation thing, I have decided to spend some extra time preparing myself for the future." Meixiu said.

Yu Rou was speechless after hearing this, and she mumbled in a low voice, "Now that you mention it... You are right... I didn't really think too much about it when I saw the news, but it looks like I should probably prepare myself just in case things get much worse."

"Anyways, since you two are busy with cultivation, I won't bother you too much. Just call me when you are finished so that we can play together in Cultivation Online, okay? It's been a while since I have seen you two, after all."

"Okay. I will call you when we plan on playing again." Meixiu said.

After hanging up the phone, Yu Rou proceeded to call Xia Jingyi.

"I hope I'm not bothering your cultivation." Yu Rou said after Xia Jingyi picked up the phone.

"Not at all."

"How's your cultivation going? Have you reached the second level yet?"

"No, I haven't. What about you?"

"Yes, I just reached it not long ago."

"Wow! Congratulations, Sister Rou! There aren't many people who have reached the 2nd level! You're definitely a cultivation genius! Most of my friends are just entering the first level, yet you're already at the second level. I think I still need at least another week or two before I can reach the 2nd level."

"Cultivation genius, huh?" A bittersweet smile appeared on Yu Rou's face.

If she was considered a cultivation genius for reaching the 2nd level in a week, what would her brother Yu Tian, who has already reached Spirit Warrior, be considered? A cultivation god?

"By the way, Sister Rou, have you heard about the cultivation schools and the cultivation factions?" Xia Jingyi suddenly asked.

"Of course. My parents have already begun creating a faction for our family. They have also spent a couple of billions recently to acquire a Heaven-rank cultivation technique." Yu Rou said.

"Heavens... Your family already has a Heaven-rank cultivation technique? My family was only able to acquire an Earth-rank cultivation technique." Xia Jingyi's disappointed voice resounded.

And she continued, "This makes me wonder if there is anyone out there with a Divine-rank cultivation technique."

Yu Rou chuckled and said, "Divine-rank cultivation techniques are simply too rare in the Lower Heavens. We'll probably have to ascend to Spirit Heaven before we can even start thinking about Divine-grade techniques."

"Oh yeah? I am willing to bet Player Yuan has a Divine-rank cultivation technique!" Xia Jingyi suddenly said.

"Player Yuan?" Yu Rou smiled and said, "If someone has a Divine-rank technique, it'd probably be him."

"If Player Yuan really has a Divine-rank cultivation technique, I wonder if he has tried to cultivate yet, and if he is already a cultivator, what level has he managed to achieve with it by now..."

"I wouldn't be surprised if he's already a Spirit Warrior." Yu Rou said with a teasing smile on her face.

"Spirit Warrior? As much as I admire Player Yuan, I think it's impossible for someone to be a Spirit Warrior already since cultivation is much slower

in the real world due to the lack of resources even if they have a Divine-rank cultivation technique." Xia Jingyi said.

Sometime later, Xia Jingyi asked, "Sister Rou, what time are you going to play Cultivation Online today?"

"I'm going to take a few days off to focus on my cultivation." Yu Rou said, and she proceeded to explain to Xia Jingyi her reason for doing so.

"I see... That makes perfect sense. Alright, I will also follow this advice and focus on my real cultivation for now. I don't want to be bullied by someone stronger, after all."

"I'll talk to you later, Sister Rou."

"Definitely."

After hanging up the phone, Yu Rou went to eat breakfast before returning to her room to spend the rest of the day cultivating.

And with everyone focused on improving their real cultivation, a week passed by in the blink of an eye.

Knock *Knock*

"Young lady, the Masters have summoned you to the main house." A servant knocked on the door to Yu Rou's room.

Yu Rou stopped her cultivation and stood up to open the door.

"Let them know that I am on my way," she said.

Sometime later, after taking a quick shower and dressing up properly, Yu Rou traveled to the Yu Family's main house where her parents were waiting.

Once Yu Rou met up with her parents at the main house, they brought her to another large building that was almost just as big as Yu Rou's house a few miles away from the main house, and inside this building were multiple

rooms with hundreds of comfortable beds lined up with the console required to play Cultivation Online set up for each bed.

"What is this?" Yu Rou asked them.

"This is the future of our Yu Family and the company." Tang Lee said with a confident smile on her face, and she continued, "It will also be where all of our players will be living and playing starting today."

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Author's Note: Check out 'Hero's Carnage', my other novel.

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Chapter 444 - Cultivators Association

Chapter 444 - Cultivators' Association

"Everyone?" Yu Rou raised her eyebrows.

Despite the luxurious background, the atmosphere of this place was a little suffocating, and Yu Rou felt like she was in a hospital or something similar.

"As you already know, we have acquired a Heaven-rank cultivation technique recently. This is where those who decide to join our Yu Family will get to practice the cultivation technique. Of course, we don't want them running away with our technique, so we'll have them cultivate in this place." Yu Yong said.

He then turned to look at Yu Rou and asked her, "What is your cultivation base right now?"

"Second Level Spirit Apprentice," she responded in a calm voice.

"Mmm. Not bad considering that you'd started only a week ago." Yu Yong nodded his head before continuing to speak, "We have sent out the applications yesterday, and in less than 24 hours, we have received over a thousand requests to join our family with most of them being at the second level and a couple at the third level. In fact, we even have someone at the fourth level."

"What? Someone has already reached the fourth level already?" Yu Rou was surprised to hear this.

Yu Yong nodded and said, "This person has been cultivating in secrecy even before the world knew that we could cultivate in the real world, so he's ahead of the majority of cultivators currently."

"Oh, that makes sense." Yu Rou didn't say anything else.

"Anyways, we called you here today to let you experience the Heaven-rank cultivation technique that we acquired recently. You only have the basic cultivation technique, right?"

"Yes..." Yu Rou nodded.

"Go pick whichever bed you want and enter Cultivation Online. Meet me at Lu City so that I can hand you the cultivation technique." Yu Yong said to her.

"Okay." Yu Rou nodded.

Although she had planned on letting Yuan find a better cultivation technique for her, since he will be busy for a while, she will have to rely on her family for a better cultivation technique for now. Furthermore, this new cultivation technique should help boost her cultivation speed in the real world as well.

Thus, Yu Rou entered the game and traveled to Lu City before meeting with Yu Yong.

Inside the game, Yu Yong and Yu Rou went to a Cultivators' Haven so that Yu Rou could learn the cultivation technique safely.

"Do you need a key for this place?" Yu Yong asked her.

"No, I already have one," she said.

After they arrived at the highest floor in the place, Yu Yong handed the cultivation technique to her and said with a solemn face, "Don't lose this. It cost us a fortune to acquire it. If you lose it, we'll sell you to make up for the losses."

Yu Rou didn't show any reaction and nodded silently.

"Let me know when you've learned the cultivation technique so that we can start training the people in our family." Yu Yong said to her before entering one of the rooms to cultivate.

Once Yu Rou entered the room and the door closed, she began trying to comprehend the Heaven-rank cultivation technique.

A week later, Yu Rou emerged from her room with a happy expression on her face.

"Finally! It took me an entire week to learn this cultivation technique!"

Besides the martial technique she'd gotten with Yuan's help, Yu Rou hasn't tried to learn another technique, hence why she was excited to finally learn something new even though it'd taken her an entire week.

Sometime later, she met up with Yu Yong again to return the cultivation technique to him.

"Now that you have a Heaven-rank cultivation technique, I expect significant improvements to your progress both in Cultivation Online and your real cultivation. Don't disappoint me." Yu Yong said to her after storing the cultivation technique inside a storage pouch.

"I understand." Yu Rou nodded.

Yu Rou logged off the game shortly after.

'I can finally go home and sleep in my own bed...' Yu Rou sighed inwardly, as she had to stay in this place until she learned the cultivation technique.

However, before she could leave the place, her mother, Tang Lee, stood before her.

"Yu Rou, make sure you register yourself as a cultivator at the Cultivators' Association that was completed just today within the next 90 days. If you don't and get caught, you'll be fined by the government and possibly go to jail." Tang Lee warned her.

"Cultivators' Association? It's already finished? I wasn't expecting it for at least a few more weeks if not months," she said.

The Cultivators' Association is a government-funded organization that was created to regulate cultivation to a certain extent, and it has governments from around the world supporting it, quickly becoming the strongest cultivation faction in the real world.

Furthermore, not only does the Cultivators' Association regulate cultivators, but they were also recruiting cultivators to assist them in maintaining public order just like the police forces.

"I understand. I will try to register today." Yu Rou said.

Thus, after leaving the place, Yu Rou made her way to the Cultivators' Association that replaced a large park in the middle of the city.

Of course, the place was crowded with people.

"Maybe I should come back another day..." Yu Rou mumbled to herself before telling the driver to go back to her house, where she started cultivating with her new cultivation technique and seeing significant improvements to her progression.

"No wonder why people are paying fortunes for better cultivation techniques... My speed almost doubled with this new cultivation technique!"

Feeling excited about her new cultivation speed, Yu Rou proceeded to spend the entire day cultivating.

Meanwhile, back at Yuan's apartment, Meixiu entered Yuan's room and said to him, "Yuan, the Cultivators' Association has been completed. We must register as a cultivator within the next 90 days or we'll be considered as illegal cultivators..."

"We have 3 months? That's plenty of time." Yuan said.

And he continued, "How's your cultivation going?"

"I just reached the fifth level," she said in a calm voice.

"Nice. I should be entering the eighth level after another week," he said.

'Eight Level Spirit Warrior...' Meixiu sighed inwardly, wondering what might happen when he has to register his cultivation at the Cultivators' Association in the near future.

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Chapter 445 - A New Rumor

A little over a week after the Cultivators' Association was announced, over 100,000 cultivators from Yuan's city alone had registered as a cultivator with less than 1 percent of them also joining the Cultivators' Association.

One percent may seem like very little, but the requirements to join the Cultivators' Association were not low, as one needed to be at least a Third Level Spirit Apprentice before they could even take the examination.

After joining the Cultivators' Association, the cultivators are given a special badge and assigned to a certain location in the city where they will be working, almost like actual police but with higher pay and more authority.

As for the number of cultivators that have registered at the Cultivators' Association worldwide, it reached 10 million people in less than a month.

Meanwhile, Yuan had reached the Eighth Level Spirit Warrior and improved immensely for his condition— to the point where he could push his upper body off the bed a few inches with his arms.

However, despite his seemingly fit physique and feeling like he was overwhelming with energy, Yuan actually couldn't exert much strength, feeling like something was blocking him from utilizing his full potential.

'Maybe Doctor Wang is right— that I might be cursed.' Yuan sighed inwardly.

Hopefully, he could sit up on the bed without external help by the time he enters the ninth level.

Sometime later, Meixiu entered his room and said, "Wang Xiuying said she'll be visiting later today for your checkup."

Now that Wang Xiuying knew his identity as Player Yuan, she has pretty much replaced Doctor Wang when it comes to taking care of him such as the weekly checkups, especially when Doctor Wang and his hospital has seen an explosive increase in patients recently due to the increased violence in the community between cultivators.

"Okay," Yuan said.

About two hours later, Wang Xiuying arrived at their apartment and began examining Yuan's condition.

"Everything looks normal this week as well." Wang Xiuying said to him afterward.

"I see. Thank you."

"What cultivation are you at right now, Yuan?" Wang Xiuying then asked him, and she continued, "I just reached the fourth level yesterday."

"Eighth level," Yuan said.

"Haaa... Looks like it's really impossible to catch up to you..." Wang Xiuying sighed.

"And no wonder why your body looks so fit despite not exercising. I thought it was weird when I first noticed it. To think it was because you'd started cultivating."

When Wang Xiuying learned that Yuan had been cultivating even before it was announced, she was obviously shocked, but what shocked her the most was when she learned that he was already a Spirit Warrior while everyone else was still a Spirit Apprentice.

Of course, there was one more thing that Yuan revealed to her.

Wang Xiuying looked at the door to make sure it was closed before asking Yuan in a low voice, "How's your recovery going compared to last week?"

Yuan proceeded to show Wang Xiuying his progress by lifting his body off the bed slightly before falling back down a moment later.

"As you can see, that's the most I can do right now," he said.

Since she was going to be his nurse, Yuan decided to reveal to her that his body was actually recovering.

"Wow, you're definitely making good progress. At this rate, you'll be able to tell Meixiu about your recovery soon."

Yuan nodded his head slightly and said, "Yes, I plan on telling her once I am able to sit up on the bed properly."

"Even though it's regrettable that I couldn't assist you in your recovery as I'd hoped, I am still happy to see you finally recovering after so many years." Wang Xiuying said to him.

"Although my body is recovering, my sight doesn't appear to be getting any better. Maybe I'll remain blind for the rest of my life," he sighed.

After a moment of silence, Wang Xiuying said, "Yuan, I don't know if this is true or fake, but I have heard a rumor going around recently— that there are other things in Cultivation Online that might affect our world such as resources. I know this sounds crazy, but so is cultivation."

"I have experimented with this rumor, but I didn't get any results, so maybe it's fake. Maybe there's some kind of requirement that one must fulfill before it takes effect, but if this is real, we might be able to fix your vision."

Yuan was surprised after hearing Wang Xiuying's words, and then he recalled the impurities that came from his body in the real world after consuming a treasure in Cultivation Online.

After pondering for some time, Yuan spoke, "Maybe... Maybe the treasure has to be of a certain quality? To tell you the truth, I think I have experienced it before."

"What?! Really?! Tell me more!" Wang Xiuying was immediately intrigued.

Yuan proceeded to tell her about the Translucent Dew of Flawlessness and how it cleaned his impurities both inside the game and the real world.

Wang Xiuying turned dead silent after hearing Yuan's story.

After a moment of silence, she said, "In order to gather further proof, we will need to obtain a high-grade treasure and test it for ourselves... I will see if my Master has any unwanted treasure since it's much easier to find higher quality treasures in the Spirit Heaven."

"Okay. I will also try to do some more experiments on my end. This will be immense if it actually works." Yuan said.

After talking for a couple more minutes with Wang Xiuying telling Yuan about her experience in the Spirit Heaven and her new sect, Wang Xiuying packed her tools and prepared to leave.

"Okay, I will see you next week, Yuan," she said to him before leaving the apartment.

"Is everything okay?" Meixiu asked him afterward.

"Yes. I am going to return to cultivation online today for a bit." Yuan said.

"Do you want me to come with you?"

"No, it's fine. I'm just going to talk with Xiao Hua and the others. I won't stay long. I want to reach the Ninth Level Spirit Warrior at the very least before I really start playing again." Yuan said.

"Okay."

Chapter 446 - Stalker

After helping Yuan with the console, Meixiu returned to her own room and continued to cultivate.

Despite not caring about cultivation before, Meixiu found a reason that motivated her to keep cultivating, and that was Yuan.

Even though Yuan was at a much higher cultivation than her, he was unable to move his body, so he was vulnerable to many things, and if the world continues to become more dangerous, it will be all up to her to protect him.

Meanwhile, the moment Yuan appeared inside Cultivation Online, Xiao Hua appeared from his necklace even before he could say anything.

"Welcome back, Brother Yuan." Xiao Hua said to him.

"Hello, Xiao Hua. Did you miss me?" Yuan said with a smile on his face, feeling like it's been forever since he last played.

Xiao Hua nodded after hearing his words.

"I missed you as well, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang's voice resounded.

"Me too." Lan Yingying as well.

"Unfortunately, I am not finished with my business yet so I won't stay here for long. I need a favor from you guys," he said a moment later.

"What do you need, Brother Yuan?" Xiao Hua asked him.

"I am in need of treasures— mostly resources with unique effects, and I need them to be at least Earth-grade," Yuan said.

Feng Yuxiang came outside and asked, "Resources above Earth-grade? What kind of treasures? Any specific effects? Like increasing your Soul Strength or something that boosts your cultivation? How many do you want? And why do you suddenly need resources, Young Master?"

"Let's see... I want the resource to do something unique— something like the Translucent Dew of Flawlessness. I don't need anything that will increase my cultivation base, and I only need one treasure from each quality from Earth-grade up to Heaven-grade. I would like to ask for Divine-grade resources, but they are too rare and I don't have enough money for them."

"As for why I need them... Well, it's for an experiment." Yuan said to them.

"Something like the Translucent Dew of Flawlessness? That's not going to be easy, Young Master. The Translucent Dew of Flawlessness is an extremely rare treasure that can only be found in the upper heavens, but I will see what I can do." Feng Yuxiang said.

Yuan then retrieved the spirit stones Xi Meili gave him and handed them to her.

"Use this to buy the resources. If it's not enough, just buy whatever you can afford with it."

Feng Yuxiang looked at the money and wanted to say that he didn't need to pay them, but knowing his character, she accepted it and said, "When do you need the resources, Young Master?"

"I don't have a time limit so you can take your time."

"I understand. I will go around and ask some of my friends." Feng Yuxiang nodded.

"Xiao Hua will also look around."

"I would love to help, but I don't know this world enough to help, and I'm not really knowledgeable when it comes to these things. I'm sorry for being useless..." Lan Yingying sighed.

"Don't worry about it, Yingying. And you're not useless." Yuan said to her.

"Just leave this to the experts. You stay with the Young Master just in case anything happens while we're away." Feng Yuxiang smiled.

Sometime later, Feng Yuxiang and Xiao Hua left the Cultivators' Haven to look for treasures for Yuan.

Once he was alone, Yuan prepared to log off.

However, right as he was about to log off, one of the doors there opened, and a beautiful young lady with silky golden hair walked outside.

This was the same fierce girl who yelled at Yuan for peeking at her—the mysterious girl from one of the Four Ancient Families.

Apparently, she has been cultivating this entire time without leaving the Cultivators' Haven, which wasn't too surprising if one thought about it since cultivation sessions usually last for weeks.

When this young lady saw Yuan standing there, she immediately frowned before approaching him in an aggressive manner, "Hey! Don't tell me that you've been standing there this entire time?! Are you stalking me or something?! Who are you!"

"What?" Yuan's eyes widened with disbelief.

"I just got here..." He said.

"Bullshit! You barely moved since I last saw you a couple of weeks ago! You're definitely a stalker!"

Once she was in front of him, the fierce girl raised her hands and prepared to slap him.

When Yuan saw this, he also raised his hand.

Whoosh!

The fierce girl swung her hands at Yuan's face, but he easily caught it.

"How can you hit people so easily? I didn't even do anything wrong! You need to stop assuming things!" Yuan said to her with a frown.

However, he cried inwardly, 'What a strong girl! I'm a Spirit Grandmaster, yet I am struggling to hold her back!'

Meanwhile, the fierce girl was also surprised that Yuan had managed to stop her strike, as this is the first time that someone has stopped her ever since she left her family to go on a journey.

Usually, she would just send them flying with a single strike and without any hassle.

"Let me go, you pervert!" The girl suddenly shouted at him.

"Only if you promise me that you won't try to hit me if I let you—"

Before Yuan could even finish his sentence, the girl suddenly jumped and spun her body in a graceful manner before sending her feet flying at his chest.

BOOM!

Yuan was sent flying to the wall after being kicked directly in the chest, causing the entire building to shake slightly and disturbing everybody that was currently cultivating inside.

"Are you okay, Yuan?!" Lan Yingying exclaimed when she saw this, even forgetting to address him as 'Lord', and she appeared beside him.

"I'm not hurt. Physical attacks won't harm me unless they come from a Spirit King." Yuan said to her.

Meanwhile, the fierce girl who'd just sent Yuan flying with a powerful kick knelt on the floor while clutching to her small feet after the kick, feeling like she'd just kicked a metal ball.

'What the heck is his body made of?! Metal?!' She cried inwardly, regretting her actions.

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Chapter 447 - Returning To The Golden Phoenix Bazaar

"Damn it! What is your body made of?! Why is it so freaking durable! It feels like I broke a bone or something!" The fierce girl cried out loud after kicking Yuan with her feet.

"You should probably stop kicking people out of nowhere. I hope you've learned your lesson." Yuan patted the dust off his clothes and approached her in a casual manner, looking like he wasn't harmed even in the slightest.

The fierce girl gritted her teeth in anger. Despite her urge to punch Yuan in the face, she didn't dare to attack him after her last strike, fearing that she might hurt herself instead.

"Anyways, I am not stalking you, nor do I have any reason to stalk you. It was merely a coincidence that I am still here." Yuan said to her.

"Yingying, let's go." Yuan proceeded to ignore the young lady and walked downstairs with Lan Yingying following behind him.

After meeting many unreasonable people, Yuan has learned that it would be easier to just ignore them and leave the scene immediately. If this fierce lady still decides to follow him, he will use his cultivation to scare her away.

"I'll remember your face! If I see you again, I am going to smash your face!"

Yuan could hear the fierce girl's voice shouting from behind him.

Once they descended a couple of floors, Lan Yingying returned to Yuan's wrist as a bracelet, and Yuan logged off on the spot. Since Meixiu was still in this place, there was no reason for them to leave.

After logging off, Yuan took a moment to clear his mind before he started cultivating towards the Ninth Level Spirit Warrior.

Meanwhile, inside Cultivation Online, after leaving Yuan's side, Feng Yuxiang and Xiao Hua left the city together before going their separate ways.

"Xiao Hua, here's the Young Master's spirit stones. I have plenty of money so I don't need it." Feng Yuxiang handed Xiao Hua the spirit stones.

Xiao Hua looked at the spirit stones for a moment before accepting it. Although she had plenty of valuable weapons, she wasn't carrying any money.

Of course, she'd planned on trading her weapons for other treasures or even selling a few of her treasures to get the necessary funds to buy the treasures.

"Let's see which of us will find the most valuable treasures for the Young Master, shall we? Don't worry, this is a friendly competition. With that being said, I don't plan on going easy on you!" Feng Yuxiang said to Xiao Hua, and she flew away before Xiao Hua could even respond.

Sometime later, Feng Yuxiang arrived at a city that had a teleportation device and used it to travel to Phoenix City.

"I didn't think I'd return to this place so soon after leaving, but when it comes to finding rare and valuable treasures, there's no better place in the Lower Heavens than Phoenix City." Feng Yuxiang hovered above the city with a smile on her face, feeling quite confident that she would win this competition.

Feng Yuxiang then flew straight into the city, landing directly in front of the Golden Phoenix Bazaar.

"Who dares—"

The guards standing there were taken by surprise by Feng Yuxiang's grand entrance and subconsciously pointed their weapons at her.

"What are you going to do with me with those toys, huh?" Feng Yuxiang glanced at them with a sharp gaze.

"M-Madam Feng?!"

When the guards realized her identity, they immediately dropped their weapons and got onto their knees.

"We apologize for pointing our weapons at you, Madam Feng!" They said in unison with sweat soaking their foreheads.

"Whatever." Feng Yuxiang said before walking past them, ignoring their offense.

"What?"

The two guards looked at Feng Yuxiang's disappearing back before looking at each other with shocked expressions on their faces.

"She's not going to punish us?"

"I was expecting a slap in the face at the very least..."

The two guards seemed surprised that Feng Yuxiang didn't punish them for disrespecting her, as she would normally do just that even if they looked at her wrongly, much less point their weapons at her.

After entering the Golden Phoenix Bazaar, Feng Yuxiang entered one of the stores there.

"Welcome to our Heaven's Resource—"

A worker standing at the entrance started his welcoming sentence even before he could see the customer's face, and when he saw Feng Yuxiang's

beautiful face, he began coughing like he'd choked on something.

"M-M-Madam Feng?!" The worker exclaimed.

"Is Zhong Li here?" she asked him.

"Y-Yes!" He nodded vigorously.

Feng Yuxiang didn't say anything else and began walking upstairs like this place was her house.

Once she was on the third floor, she knocked on the only door on that floor and entered it without waiting for a response.

Inside the room, a middle-aged man in black robes and a young woman wearing similar clothes to the worker at the entrance were flirting with each other.

"Who dares?!" The middle-aged man slammed the desk in anger before turning around to look at the beautiful woman standing at the entrance.

The middle-aged man gasped in shock when he saw Feng Yuxiang standing there with an angry look on her face.

Feeling the suffocating atmosphere, the young woman quickly tightened her loosened clothes before running out of the room.

"M-M-Madam Feng... When did you come back? And where have you been recently? The Golden Phoenix Bazaar isn't the same without your presence..." The middle-aged man quickly changed the topic and acted like nothing just happened.

Feng Yuxiang closed her eyes for a moment to calm down before speaking, "I'm here to collect your debt, Zhong Li."

The middle-aged man named Zhong Li swallowed nervously and asked, "W-What do you want?"

"Nothing much. Just a few treasures from your store." Feng Yuxiang said.

"T-That's it?" Zhong Li looked surprised at her response, and it was even a pleasant one.

"If you want me to take everything in your store, I wouldn't mind doing so." Feng Yuxiang said to him.

"P-Please have mercy!" Zhong Li quickly got off his seat and kowtowed to her.

"Then I'll go look around." Feng Yuxiang said, ignoring him entirely.

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Chapter 448 - Her Reason For Leaving

After spending about an hour in Zhong Li's store looking for the perfect treasure for Yuan, she left the place with a couple of new treasures in her storage ring.

"Are you coming back to the Golden Phoenix Bazaar?" Zhong Li asked Feng Yuxiang right before she left the place.

"No, I am not," she said.

"I have more important things to do now."

"I see..." Zhong Li nodded.

After leaving Zhong Li's store, Feng Yuxiang didn't leave the city and proceeded to enter the next store.

"You Quan, I am here to collect the debt you owe me when I helped you set up your store!" Feng Yuxiang said to the owner of that store.

"Madam Feng! Where have you been?" You Quan asked after seeing her.

"That doesn't matter. I didn't come all the way here just for you to question me." Feng Yuxiang said.

You Quan sighed in a tired manner before speaking, "What do you want from me? If it's within my power—"

"I don't need your help. It's your treasure that I need."

"My treasures?" You Quan looked at her with wide eyes.

In the entire Golden Phoenix Bazaar, Feng Yuxiang had the best store with the most valuable treasures. Why would she need something from his store that was small and worthless in comparison?

"What kind of treasure?" He then asked.

"I don't care as long as it's unique."

"Unique...?" You Quan raised his eyebrows.

Then he said, "Why don't you look around the store? If you want something, just let me know."

Feng Yuxiang nodded and proceeded to spend another hour in this store looking for treasures.

"Are you sure you only want these treasures?" You Quan asked her afterward.

"Yes, and I will consider your debt cleared for these treasures," she said.

"Deal!" You Quan did not hesitate and immediately responded.

The treasures Feng Yuxiang took from his store were worth at least a few hundred million gold coins, yet You Quan seemed eager to give these treasures to her as long as it cleared his debt.

One can only imagine the reason being that You Quan's debt was actually worth more than the treasures Feng Yuxiang took.

After leaving You Quan's store, Feng Yuxiang continued to enter other stores to collect peoples' debt in the form of their treasures, and it seemed like every person in the Golden Phoenix Bazaar was in some sort of debt for some reason.

By the time Feng Yuxiang was done collecting their debts, she had acquired over 100 treasures from the Earth-grade to the Heaven-grade, and she had

even managed to obtain a Divine-grade treasure that was worth billions of gold coins.

"The Young Master will definitely praise me once he sees this many treasures..." A wide grin appeared on Feng Yuxiang's face as she imagined the scene in her mind.

However, her imagination was quickly interrupted by a voice.

"Madam Feng!"

A man's voice resounded, wiping the smile off Feng Yuxiang's face.

She turned around to see a middle-aged man and a group of guards behind him.

"What do you want, Jin Yupu? I have already decided to leave the city, and I most likely won't be coming back here," she said to him.

"You won't be able to convince me to come back," she added.

"I know... I am not here to convince you to stay in the city. I just want to know your reason for leaving. Did something happen? Was it caused by the city? Or was it caused by my family? I won't be able to sleep properly without an answer, and I haven't been able to sleep a full night since you closed your store." Jin Yupu said to her.

Feng Yuxiang's departure was a huge blow to Phoenix City's income since her store earned them more money than everyone else combined—for the last few hundred years, and as the lord of the city, it was only natural for Jin Yupu to want to figure out why she left.

If it was his city that chased her away, he'd reform the city from the bottom to the top. If someone in his family had offended her, he'd disown that person. And if someone in the city had offended her, he'd give that individual a public execution—that was how much Jin Yupu valued Feng Yuxiang's presence.

"If I tell you, will you stop bothering me?" Feng Yuxiang said.

"I promise." He nodded.

Feng Yuxiang took a deep breath and then said, "I have found someone I want to serve— a Master. And I am currently following him right now. Sooner or later, we'll leave the Lower Heavens. This is why I cannot stay here anymore."

"What....?" Jin Yupu and everyone there looked at her with wide eyes.

Feng Yuxiang, the number one expert in Phoenix City had abandoned her priceless store not because someone had offended her but because she lowered her head for someone else, becoming their servant? How could that even be possible? Surely, they must be dreaming.

"A-Are you serious, Madam Feng? Nobody offended you, causing you to leave the city?" Jin Yupu was clearly in disbelief.

After all, there was no way that a peak Spirit Grandmaster like Feng Yuxiang could become a servant for another person, especially if they consider her arrogant and prideful demeanor.

"Don't look down on my Young Master. He's a once-in-a-lifetime genius who will surely dominate the Nine Heavens one day, and I want to be there to witness it. Although I had a different goal when I first met him, after spending some time with him, I have decided that I want to follow him to the end." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Now that you know why I am leaving, you can stop bothering me. See ya." Feng Yuxiang then flew into the sky before disappearing into the distance, leaving Jin Yupu and the others speechless.

"I have acquired more treasures than I'd anticipated. Hopefully, this means the Young Master will praise me more... Hehe..." Feng Yuxiang chuckled to herself as she sped back to Long Chen City.

Chapter 449 - Do You Think It Exists?

Another week has passed since Yuan asked Feng Yuxiang and Xiao Hua to look for treasures, and Wang Xiuying arrived at their apartment for another weekly checkup.

"Yuan, I have consumed a couple of Earth-grade treasures and even one Heaven-grade treasure, but none of them affected my real body." Wang Xiuying said to him.

"What? You have already acquired the treasures? That was quick." Yuan said to her.

"Well, it's not hard when you're one of the most prominent disciples in the Spirit Healing Academy." Wang Xiuying said in a prideful tone.

"My master usually gives me all of the resources I need if I ask nicely and it's a reasonable amount," she continued.

Before joining the Spirit Healing Academy, Wang Xiuying had to undertake their disciple examination, and to their surprise, she passed it with flying colors, even obtaining a high score that their sect hadn't seen in a very long time.

Thus, Wang Xiuying had instantly become the Spirit Healing Academy's treasure—one of their most valued disciples, and this gave her a lot of privileges and benefits, one of them being that she almost had unlimited resources to supply her growth.

As a result, in just a single month, Wang Xiuying's cultivation base soared to the peak of Spirit Warrior, becoming a top player in Cultivation Online.

Of course, Wang Xiuying wasn't the only player to experience significant progress and growth, as Lightning Emperor, the other player who ascended with her, also experienced similar growth.

"So treasures below Heaven-grade don't work, huh... Maybe we need to consume Divine-grade treasures." Yuan mumbled.

"Who knows. Maybe it really works but with a much lower chance, and higher grade treasures will have a higher chance for it to transfer to our real bodies." Wang Xiuying said.

After a moment of silence, she continued, "Hey, Yuan, this may sound like an odd question, but do you think the world inside Cultivation Online actually exists somewhere in this seemingly boundless universe? Like another world?"

"Cultivation Online... exists?" Yuan mumbled in a dazed voice.

Although he never mentioned it to anyone fearing that they might call him crazy, he has indeed had such thoughts before.

"I mean, how else can you explain the cultivation phenomenon and other things? I am not the only one with such thoughts. There are many people questioning why cultivation techniques in Cultivation Online work in our world, and there are already plenty of theories about the cultivation world being real."

"I kind of believe it, but it's also quite unbelievable at the same time. What do you think?"

A smile appeared on Yuan's face as she spoke in a longing voice, "If the world of cultivation truly exists, how nice would that be? I mean, if you ignore the unreasonable people, the cultivation world is such a wonderful place that's filled with mysteries and miracles. I wouldn't mind it at all if it really exists."

"Yes, I think so, too." Wang Xiuying said.

Sometime later, right before Wang Xiuying left, Yuan said to her, "I am going to log in today to see if the others have returned yet. I'll let you know the results soon."

"Okay. I'll be waiting." Wang Xiuying said.

After Wang Xiuying left, Yuan asked Meixiu, "How's your cultivation?"

"I should be entering the sixth level in a few days," she calmly responded.

"I see... Can you enter the game with me today? I am doing an experiment," he then said.

"What kind of experiment?"

"Whether or not treasures inside Cultivation Online will affect our real bodies."

"What...?" Meixiu mumbled in a dumbfounded voice.

"I know it sounds crazy but hear me out..." Yuan proceeded to tell Meixiu about the impurity incident as well as the recent rumor regarding the topic.

"If this is true... I cannot even imagine what could happen..." Meixiu said afterward.

"Right? Therefore, we're going to test it out— using our own bodies."

"This is crazy..." Meixiu sighed.

What if these treasures actually work? Will there be any side effects afterward?

In the end, Meixiu gave up and entered Cultivation Online with Yuan.

Inside Cultivation Online, Yuan went back upstairs to meet up with Meixiu, as he was forced to leave before by that fierce girl.

'Hopefully, she's gone by now...' Yuan sighed inwardly as he approached the top floor.

"Feng Feng, Xiao Hua, can you hear me?" Yuan tried to speak with them through their servant-master connection.

"Yes, I can hear you, Young Master. Are you still at the Cultivators' Haven? I will be there in a minute." Feng Yuxiang responded a moment later.

As for Xiao Hua, Yuan has yet to hear a response from her even after Feng Yuxiang showed up.

"Xiao Hua is not with you?" Yuan asked her.

Feng Yuxiang shook her head and said, "We went our separate ways."

"I see... Then she's probably too far away to hear my voice. I hope she's okay." Yuan said.

"There's nothing in the Lower Heavens that can harm her so you don't have to worry," said Feng Yuxiang.

"I hope that's the case."

Sometime later, Yuan entered one of the cultivation rooms with Meixiu and Feng Yuxiang.

"Here you go."

Once they had some privacy, Feng Yuxiang proceeded to retrieve the treasures she had acquired at the Golden Phoenix Bazaar.

Yuan and Meixiu were shaken when they saw the number of treasures Feng Yuxiang had acquired.

"Y-You obtained this many treasures with the number of spirit stones I gave you?" Yuan asked her in a trembling voice.

Feng Yuxiang showed a stiff smile and said, "Y-Yes... I went to speak with my friends, and I managed to get them at a discounted price because they owed me."

"Even if there was a discount... I still can't believe that you'd obtained this many treasures with the spirit stones I gave you! Look at this! There's even a Divine-grade treasure in here! Are you telling me that you got everything here for less than 1,000 spirit stones?! That's only worth around 10 million gold coins!" Yuan said to her, clearly doubting her claims.

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Chapter 450 - Longevity Seed

"Fine, I'll tell you the truth, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang sighed, and then she continued, "Truth is, they were given to me for free."

"What? That sounds even less likely!" Yuan said.

After all, who would give up such precious treasures for free?

"I'm telling you the truth, Young Master. I went to the Golden Phoenix Bazaar to acquire these treasures," she said.

"Golden Phoenix Bazaar?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

She nodded and said, "I know everybody that owns a store there, and they're all indebted to me, so I decided to go there to collect their debt since I will be leaving this place soon, and they gave me these treasures to clear their debt. I guess these treasures weren't free technically, but let's not ponder about the minor stuff."

Feng Yuxiang told him the truth.

"Do you see any treasures that you want, Young Master?" she then asked him again.

"Hmm..." Yuan looked at the treasures and said, "I will have to look through them one by one first."

"Take your time," she said.

"Anyways, thank you, Feng Feng. I owe you for this." Yuan then said to her.

"I'm just doing my job," she said with a smile.

"If you want, I can give you some of my blood later."

However, to Yuan's surprise, Feng Yuxiang shook her head and refused to take his blood.

"It's okay, Young Master. You can save your blood."

"Eh? Really? Are you okay? You would normally be excited to drink it..." Yuan said with a surprised look on his face, wondering if something had happened.

Feng Yuxiang showed a stiff smile and said, "Everything is fine. There are just days where I have no appetite for anything."

"I see... Well, if you ever feel like drinking it again, just let me know."

"Okay. Thank you, Young Master."

Ever since Xiao Hua told her that she might be forced to ascend to a higher realm if she breaks free from her curse and restores her cultivation base, Feng Yuxiang has become hesitant on drinking Yuan's blood, especially when she could feel the curse weakening with every sip.

'I will continue to drink his blood once we reach Spirit Heaven where there's a bigger limit. Until then, I will have to resist myself from drinking any of his blood...' Feng Yuxiang sighed inwardly.

Yuan began looking through the pile of treasures a moment later, and he would spend the next hour doing so.

An hour later, Yuan sighed, "Even though there are so many treasures here, none of them are really unique enough for my experiment..."

"What experiment?" Feng Yuxiang looked at him with wide eyes.

Was all of her efforts in vain?

"It's hard to explain it..." Yuan said.

After all, how would he go about telling her that he's testing to see if the treasures inside a game would affect his real body?

He then said, "All of these treasures enhance one's strength or permanently enhance one's stats. There's really nothing truly unique about them. Isn't there something that can make my hair grow longer or something?"

"Making the Young Master's hair grow longer?" Feng Yuxiang raised her eyebrows.

Then she retrieved something from her spatial ring and showed it to him, "This is Longevity Seed. If you consume it, it'll grant you 100 years of longevity and even give you new hair. It's really popular amongst men who are balding."

Yuan looked at the seed with raised eyebrows. He didn't literally mean it when he said that he wanted something that could grow his hair, as it was just an example.

"I mean, it's an Earth-grade treasure, so I guess I can try it."

"Thanks, Feng Feng." Yuan accepted the Longevity Seed and tossed it inside his mouth.

After chewing it a couple of times, he swallowed it.

Ding!

<You have consumed Longevity Seed>

<You have gained 100 years of longevity from consuming Longevity Seed!>

After consuming the seed, Yuan stood there and waited for his hair to grow.

However, to his surprise, his hair began falling off his head instead, instantly making him bald!

"What!" Yuan was shocked when he saw this.

"Feng Feng! You lied to me! This thing is doing the exact opposite of what you said!" Yuan looked at her with a frown on his face.

"Pft..." Feng Yuxiang almost burst out laughing when she saw Yuan's bald appearance.

Meixiu was no different, and she tried her best to resist her urges.

"W-Wait a moment, Young Master. I didn't lie to you," Feng Yuxiang then said, "Your hair will grow back in a bit. The treasure killed all of your old hair to remake new ones."

And just like Feng Yuxiang claimed, silky black hair began emerging from Yuan's bald head shortly after.

However, it grew more than he expected, and by the time it stopped growing, his new hair had reached his butt.

"There's too much hair now..." Yuan sighed.

"Now I have to get a haircut," he then said.

"Why? I think you look much better with long hair, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang said to him.

"Here. You can use this to tie your hair."

She then handed him a golden hairband.

"I guess this will do for now..." Yuan then tied his long and silky hair into a ponytail.

"Now you look more like a cultivator, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang chuckled.

"Oh... And more handsome."

"Handsome? Wouldn't this make me look more feminine instead?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"What do you think, Meixiu?" He suddenly asked her.

"Eh?" Meixiu was taken by surprise, and when she saw his new appearance that had a certain charm and elegance to it, she began blushing.

"I-I think it's fine," she finally said after a moment of awkward silence.

"Okay, then we will be right back. Meixiu, I need you to check my hair for me." Yuan said to her before logging off shortly after.

Sometime later, Meixiu went to his room.

"Well? Did my hair grow longer?" Yuan asked her.

"No... Nothing happened," she said.

"I see... Then let's go try some more treasures."

The two of them returned to the game a moment later and began looking through the treasures again.

Chapter 451 - Berserker's Gem

"What about this one, Yuan? It can boost your eyesight and reaction by a significant amount," Meixiu showed him a weird-looking fruit.

"You can eat it. I have already eaten one." Yuan said to her.

Meixiu nodded and consumed the Earth-grade treasure a moment later.

Ding!

<You have consumed Fruit of Perception>

A few moments later, Meixiu said, "Wow, my eyesights got noticeably better after consuming the treasure, and I can see details that I wouldn't normally be able to before. I'm not sure about my reaction speed though—"

Meixiu suddenly stopped speaking and tilted her head when she noticed something flying at her face with incredible speed.

"Y-Yuan?" Meixiu looked at him with wide eyes.

"Sorry, I just wanted to test your reaction." Yuan chuckled a little before retrieving his arm.

"What do you think? Has your reaction gotten better?"

"P-Probably..." she said.

"Now see if these changes apply outside." Yuan then said.

Meixiu nodded and logged off the game shortly after to see the results.

She returned a few moments later and shook her head, "I don't think it worked."

"What about this treasure? It's a Heaven-grade treasure, and it boosts your strength significantly." Yuan asked.

"You want me to take this treasure as well?"

"I mean, I wouldn't be able to test the results even if I use it," Yuan said with a stiff smile on his face.

"Oh... Okay..." Meixiu realized what Yuan was trying to say and subconsciously nodded.

Ding!

<You have consumed Berserker's Gem>

<+20,000 Physical Strength>

"That's a lot of strength..." Meixiu muttered in a dazed voice before logging off to see if her physical strength had improved.

'How should I go about testing my strength? As a cultivator, I am already strong enough to lift an entire desk without any issues...' Meixiu wondered to herself as she looked around her room for something extremely heavy.

However, there was nothing in her room that would challenge her already profound strength.

After pondering for some time, Meixiu decided to go outside the apartment where plenty of heavy objects were available.

She then approached one of the cars parked in front of the apartment before looking left and right to make sure nobody was looking at her.

Once she was clear, Meixiu bent her knees and tried to pick up the car.

As ridiculous and embarrassing as it felt, Meixiu was also curious about the rumor.

When she had a good grip on the car, Meixiu tried to stand up with the car.

"?!?!?!"

The moment she stood up, the car in her grasp also went up with her.

This shocked her so much that she accidentally dropped the car back down.

Meixiu looked left and right again to make sure nobody saw her before she ran back into the apartment.

"I-I am only dreaming, right?" Meixiu looked at her own palms with clear disbelief on her face.

After taking a moment to calm down, Meixiu went inside her room and tried to lift her bed.

Although she could lift her bed before she consumed the treasure, it wasn't easy.

Once she had a good grip on the bed, Meixiu took a deep breath before lifting the bed into the air like it weighed nothing.

"Heavens..." Meixiu mumbled in a dazed voice as she stared at the bed that was directly above her head.

And to make sure it wasn't just a fluke, Meixiu began benching the bed as though it were a barbell.

After benching the bed a dozen times, Meixiu carefully placed the bed back down onto the floor without a single bead of sweat on her face or body.

"I-It's real... The treasure inside the game really affected my real body..."

After taking a moment to calm down, Meixiu returned to Cultivation Online to share her results.

"That took longer than I expected. How did it go?" Yuan asked her when Meixiu finally logged back in after many minutes.

Meixiu stared at Yuan in silence before speaking in a low voice, "It worked..."

"Huh?" Yuan's eyes widened.

"The experiment worked..." Meixiu said, and she proceeded to tell him her experience.

"The Heaven-grade treasure worked on you but it didn't work on Wang Xiuying? I guess this proves that every treasure has a chance to transfer its effects outside, and the chances will depend on the grade of the treasure..." Yuan said in an excited voice.

Meanwhile, Feng Yuxiang looked at them with a weird expression on her face, as she was unable to comprehend their situation.

"Anyways, thank you for the treasures. You can keep the rest for yourself since we no longer need it." Yuan said to Feng Yuxiang afterward.

"O-Okay..." Feng Yuxiang nodded and stored the rest of the treasures into her spatial ring.

Sometime later, Yuan said to her, "Feng Feng, can you stay here and wait for Xiao Hua? I'm not sure when she'll come back, though."

"I don't mind." Feng Yuxiang nodded.

"I will come back at least once a day just in case she comes back," he then said.

Yuan and Meixiu logged off the game shortly after to discuss the results even more.

"Can you call Wang Xiuying later and tell her to visit us tomorrow? I'd like to tell her the results of our experiments." Yuan said to Meixiu.

"Okay."

"Anyways, although I was already quite confident that the rumors were true, seeing it happen again is another thing." Yuan then said.

"Do you know what this means, Yuan?" Meixiu said.

"As long as one is lucky enough, they might be able to use treasures from Cultivation Online to benefit their real body. This might be quite disastrous if the world finds out about it if they haven't already."

"I'm sure some people already know this, just like how people knew about cultivation way before it was announced. It's only a matter of when it becomes widespread, and when that happens, the world will become even crazier."

"What should we do?" Meixiu asked.

"Is there even anything we can do?" Yuan sighed.

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Chapter 452 - Peak Of Spirit Warrior

"I think the only thing we can do is prepare ourselves for it. Though I don't think it'll be that bad due to the rarity of treasures. Maybe I'm wrong, who knows..." Yuan sighed.

"If the chances of acquiring its effects are really low, it might not be that bad. And according to my research, the majority of the playerbase are only just starting to obtain Earth-grade treasures with Heaven-grade treasures and above still unattainable besides those really wealthy and powerful players who just buy them using real money." Meixiu said.

"There's no use thinking about it now. Let's just focus on cultivation so when the world learns about this and evolves once again, we'll be prepared for it." Yuan said.

"Yes, I agree." Meixiu nodded.

Sometime later, they started their cultivation.

The following day, Wang Xiuying returned to their apartment.

"What's up, Yuan? Did you need to speak with me? Does it have anything to do with your condition?" she asked him.

"No, this is about our experiment. We have some results." Yuan said to her.

"What! Really?!" Wang Xiuying instantly became excited.

"Yes." Yuan proceeded to explain to Wang Xiuying everything that had occurred yesterday.

Wang Xiuying silently stared at Meixiu after hearing everything.

"Y-You can lift a car with your bare hands?" Wang Xiuying asked her in a somewhat doubtful voice.

"Yes. I know it sounds crazy, but..." Meixiu nodded.

"It's alright. I believe you. I was just expressing my disbelief that it actually worked." Wang Xiuying said.

"You said that it was a Heaven-grade treasure that you'd consumed, right? I also consumed a Heaven-grade treasure, but nothing happened to me, so I guess there's only a chance of obtaining the effects."

"What are you going to do now, Yuan?" Wang Xiuying then asked him.

"What do you want me to do?" He asked her in return.

"I... I don't know... But I know what I am going to do." Wang Xiuying chuckled.

"I am going to consume all of the treasures I can! Hopefully, I will eventually get lucky and strengthen my real body through the treasures in Cultivation Online."

Wang Xiuying announced her plans.

"Actually, you should also do the same, Yuan. Maybe there's a treasure in Cultivation Online that will be able to fix your eyesight and heal your body!"

Hearing this, Meixiu also said, "Now that you mention it, there are countless miraculous treasures in Cultivation Online with profound effects one cannot even imagine! I'm sure there are treasures out there that can help you!"

"I think so, too. However, we should still focus on cultivating our real bodies first. I am going to enter the ninth level first before trying to

breakthrough to Spirit Master. Once I do that, I will focus on Cultivation Online." Yuan said.

"Good luck, Yuan. I am going to see if there's anything I can do to help in the Spirit Heavens. Maybe my Master will know something about your condition. I'll ask her." Wang Xiuying said.

"Okay. Thank you."

Wang Xiuying left shortly after while Yuan and Meixiu returned to their cultivation.

For the next couple of days, Yuan would spend most of his time cultivating towards the ninth level Spirit Warrior while also checking Cultivation Online to see if Xiao Hua had returned yet.

A week later, Yuan entered the ninth level, feeling an outburst of energy coming from somewhere within his body, yet he could not pinpoint the location.

"Xiao Hua still hasn't returned yet? She's gone for so long that it's a little worrisome..." Yuan sighed when Feng Yuxiang told him she hadn't returned yet.

"Who knows where she went. However, for her to take this long, she's either in trouble or she went really far to get the treasure." Feng Yuxiang said.

"However, with her cultivation base, I doubt it would take this long even if she had to travel to the other side of the world."

"Alright. I will continue to check if she has returned every day. Thank you for doing this, Feng Feng. I know this is probably very boring for you since you have to sit here all day." Yuan said to her.

"Don't mention it, Young Master. It's really not that bad. As someone who has lived for thousands of years, how I experience time may differ from your experience."

Sometime later, Yuan logged off and continued to cultivate.

One week...

Two weeks...

Three weeks...

An entire month has passed since Yuan reached the ninth level of Spirit Warrior, and he has reached the peak of Spirit Warrior, being only a step from entering Spirit Master.

However, this single step was by no means small, and even after trying to breakthrough for an entire week, Yuan remained stuck as a Spirit Warrior.

Meanwhile, Meixiu had managed to enter the eighth level of Spirit Apprentice, preparing to enter the ninth level.

"I entered Spirit Master as easily as breathing in Cultivation Online, yet I cannot do the same in the real world. This also happened when I tried to enter Spirit Warrior. I guess I can only continue trying..." He sighed.

After spending a few hours trying to breakthrough and failing, Yuan decided to enter Cultivation Online to see if Xiao Hua has returned yet.

"Is there anything I can do to contact her?" Yuan asked Feng Yuxiang, as he was getting impatient waiting for Xiao Hua, worried that something might've happened to her.

"Normally, you can speak with us telepathically because of the Master and Servant connection between us, but that only works for a certain amount of distance. Once we are outside the range, we won't be able to hear your voice."

"I see... Guess I can only keep trying to contact her."

After taking a deep breath, Yuan closed his eyes and proceeded to spend the next couple of minutes calling Xiao Hua.

Many minutes later with no result, Yuan prepared to log off.

However, just as he gave up, he could hear a familiar voice resound in his head.

"Sorry for making you wait, Brother Yuan."

Hearing Xiao Hua's voice, Yuan was ecstatic.

"Xiao Hua! You're back!" He exclaimed.

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Chapter 453 - Xiao Hua Returns

After hearing Xiao Hua's voice, Yuan decided to stay in the game for a little longer to see why it'd taken her this long to return and where she'd gone.

A few minutes later, Xiao Hua returned to the Cultivators' Haven.

"Thank the heavens you're okay, Xiao Hua. I was worried that something bad might've happened to you because you have been gone for so long!" Yuan gave her a tight hug after seeing her again.

Xiao Hua didn't immediately respond and merely enjoyed the sensation of being hugged by Yuan while silently blushing.

"By the way, I returned after just two days." Feng Yuxiang said to her.

"I'm sorry, Brother Yuan, but Xiao Hua wanted to fulfill your request, so Xiao Hua did her best trying to find a unique treasure," she said.

She then reached inside her storage pouch before taking out a small glass bottle of semi-transparent azure-colored liquid that had around 1 ounce of liquid inside.

"What is this?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"Celestial Water." Xiao Hua said in a calm voice.

"W-What did you just say?" Feng Yuxiang was the first to speak, and she sounded like she was in disbelief.

"Celestial Water." Xiao Hua repeated.

"Celestial Water?! Impossible! Where in heaven's name did you go to obtain Celestial Water?! I refuse to believe that you have found that in the Lower Heavens! Even the Spirit Heaven wouldn't have something like this!" Feng Yuxiang quickly said.

"What's so valuable about this Celestial Water?" Yuan asked.

"Celestial Water is from an extremely rare treasure known as the Celestial Tree. This treasure can only be found in the fifth heaven and above, and the Celestial Tree can only produce one drop of Celestial Water every 10,000 years! An ounce of Celestial Water is worth even more than Mythic-grade treasures!" Feng Yuxiang explained.

"Furthermore, Celestial Water has the ability to increase one's innate talent by at least 10 percent! Although it only works if you drink an ounce at a time, it's still incredibly sought after! That bottle of Celestial Water can start even a huge war if people know about it!"

"Increasing one's talent by at least 10 percent? That is definitely unique and sounds very expensive... How on earth did you acquire such a treasure, Xiao Hua? And where did you go to obtain it?" Yuan asked her.

"..."

After a moment of silence, she said, "Xiao Hua went to the upper heavens to obtain the Celestial Water."

Both Yuan and Feng Yuxiang's jaws dropped after hearing her words.

"Y-You went to the upper heavens for this?" Yuan almost couldn't believe his ears.

It now made sense why it took so long for Xiao Hua to return. To think she'd traveled to the upper heavens during this time. He was speechless.

"If you don't mind me asking, exactly how far did you go?" Feng Yuxiang asked her.

However, Xiao Hua remained silent, clearly unwilling to reveal everything.

Yuan and Feng Yuxiang looked at each other, unsure how they should react anymore.

"Does Brother Yuan not like it?" Xiao Hua asked him a moment later.

"Eh? Of course, I like it. In fact, I am flattered that you'd gone all the way to the upper heavens to acquire such a valuable treasure for me. I just don't know how to react..." He quickly said.

Xiao Hua nodded, and then she turned to look at Feng Yuxiang, "What treasures did you acquire for Brother Yuan?"

Obviously, Xiao Hua didn't forget about their 'friendly competition', hence why she even bothered to ask Feng Yuxiang in the first place.

A bittersweet smile appeared on Feng Yuxiang's face, and she said, "Y-You win this one. There's no way my treasures could compare with your Celestial Water even if I had a carriage-load of them."

Xiao Hua nodded in a calm manner, yet there was a glint of delight within her eyes.

"Here, Brother Yuan, you should drink it." Xiao Hua offered this priceless treasure that even Immortals would kill for to Yuan in a casual manner.

"A-Are you sure? It must've cost a fortune, right? I highly doubt my spirit stones were able to pay for even a small fraction of its price..." Yuan said.

"It's okay. Xiao Hua didn't have to pay for it," she said, shocking them even more.

"What? You're telling me that you'd manage to obtain the Celestial Water for free? As if I'd believe that!" Feng Yuxiang said afterward.

"It's true." Xiao Hua said, not even bothering to explain herself.

"If you say so, I will drink it. I don't want your effort to go to waste, after all." Yuan said.

No matter how she'd acquired this treasure, it was a fact that she'd gone all the way to the upper heavens to obtain this treasure for him.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan removed the seal on the glass bottle and chugged the Celestial Water down in a single gulp.

"Whoa!"

Yuan immediately kneeled on the floor after he drank the Celestial Water, feeling his entire body heating up at a significant rate.

"W-What is this? I feel so hot!" Yuan exclaimed, recalling when he'd first awakened his bloodline, as this was a familiar feeling.

However, unlike previously, he didn't feel any pain from the heat no matter how hot it felt.

In fact, he didn't feel any discomfort.

Yuan's eyes suddenly began flickering with a golden glow, almost like his Dragon's Gaze was activating and deactivating itself continuously.

"Is this supposed to happen?" Feng Yuxiang asked Xiao Hua.

This is her first time witnessing someone consuming Celestial Water, too.

"I... I don't know..." she said, as this was her first time witnessing it as well.

Meanwhile, somewhere in the upper heavens, the jade tablet with the word 'Destiny' engraved into it began glowing once again.

When this happened, an old man suddenly appeared before it like a ghost, and he proceeded to stare at the jade tablet with a profound look on his face.

"The jade tablet is reacting once again, yet I cannot sense your presence... Just where in the Nine Heavens are you, Master?" The old man muttered in a low voice.

Chapter 454 - Black Pajamas

A couple of minutes had passed since Yuan consumed the Celestial Water, and the heat in his body had finally subsided.

"Young Master, are you okay?" Feng Yuxiang asked him afterward.

"Yes... I am fine." Yuan said as he stood up, feeling a little lightheaded.

"Do you feel any different?" Xiao Hua asked him.

Yuan patted himself and shook his head, "No, I don't..."

In fact, he didn't even get any notification.

Normally, whenever he consumes a treasure, it would be followed by a notification and how it's affected his body. However, there was nothing this time. No notifications— nothing.

This was incredibly odd. Does this mean the Celestial Water didn't affect him at all? But how is that possible? Clearly, his body reacted to it.

"Nothing at all? How weird. The Celestial Water is a priceless treasure even in the Supreme Heaven." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Maybe it takes time to take effect?" Xiao Hua theorized.

"That makes sense. Maybe it'll take effect later once your body fully absorbs it. There are many treasures like that out there." Feng Yuxiang agreed.

"Okay. Guess I'll just have to wait and see." Yuan nodded.

Sometime later, Feng Yuxiang and Xiao Hua returned to his body before Yuan logged off the game to cultivate.

Now that Xiao Hua has returned safely, Yuan was able to cultivate with a peaceful mind.

However, he quickly noticed a change in the way that he cultivated— that it'd suddenly become easier to cultivate.

Normally, he'd need to clear his mind and recite the cultivation technique inside his mind to absorb spiritual energy.

Now, he could absorb the spiritual energy around him as though it was natural, almost like breathing.

Unfortunately for him, even if he could cultivate easier, it wouldn't matter since he cannot obtain any more spiritual energy until he breakthrough to Spirit Master.

'I think there is a term for this... What was it? A bottleneck?' Yuan sighed inwardly.

Sometime later, Yuan thought to himself, 'Since I cannot advance my cultivation anymore, I should practice something else... like my Divine Sense...'

Ever since he started focusing on his cultivation base, Yuan had neglected training his Divine Sense.

In fact, it has been a while since he tried to activate his Divine Sense.

'The last time I tried, it felt like I was on the verge of succeeding. Now that I am at the peak of Spirit Warrior, I might be able to do it...'

After taking a deep breath, Yuan began trying to activate his Divine Sense again.

Meanwhile, in the room beside Yuan's room, Meixiu suddenly opened her eyes and looked at the ceiling for some reason.

'It's probably just my imagination...' Meixiu thought to herself.

However, unbeknownst to Meixiu, somebody was actually staring at her.

"I-It worked!" Yuan exclaimed in an excited voice when his Divine Sense activated properly, allowing him to see inside his room and half of Meixiu's room.

How long has it been since he was able to see? Almost a decade ago.

Once Yuan was certain that his Divine Sense was working, tears flowed down his face, quickly soaking the pillow.

"Are you okay, Yuan?" Meixiu asked him from outside when she heard his shouting.

"Yes, I am okay."

Yuan said as his Divine Sense focused onto Meixiu's beautiful face.

Although he was already used to seeing her face, there was just something different about seeing her in the real world. Compared to her avatar in Cultivation Online, Meixiu looked almost identical with the only thing being different was their aura.

And just as Meixiu prepared to return to her own room to cultivate, Yuan's voice resounded.

"Meixiu, you look great in those black pajamas."

"Eh?"

Meixiu's movement froze the moment she heard this, and she turned to look at his room with a look of disbelief on her face.

"W-What did you just say?" she asked him in a dazed voice.

Yuan chuckled and said, "You should see your face right now. It's quite funny."

A shiver went down Meixiu's spine. Why does it sound like Yuan can see her right now?

"What's going on Yuan?" Meixiu decided to enter his room and ask him.

The first thing she noticed when she entered his room was the smile on his face, and then the tears flowing down his closed eyes.

"W-Why are you crying?" she asked him.

"Because I can see," he responded.

"What?" Meixiu's eyes widened.

"I can see again, Meixiu. I can use Divine Sense to see." Yuan revealed to her.

"W-Wait a moment... You can use Divine Sense? Right now?"

"Yes. I am looking at you right now through Divine Sense. You're wearing a pair of black pajamas, right?"

Meixiu had to look down at her own clothes to make sure he was correct, and sure enough, she was wearing black pajamas.

"Unbelievable..." Meixiu muttered in a dazed voice.

"However, it's a little exhausting to use it continuously."

Once she'd calmed down enough, Meixiu said with a warm smile on her face, "Congratulations, Yuan. This is one massive step towards your recovery."

"Yes, I think so, too. However, there's one more thing I want to tell you..." Yuan suddenly said.

"What is it?"

"Come closer," he said.

Meixiu nodded and approached him, feeling a little nervous for some reason.

Once she was by the bed, Yuan said, "Give me your hand for a moment."

"My hand?" Meixiu raised her eyebrow.

"Yes. Place it on my chest," he said.

Meixiu didn't know what he was trying to do, but she kneeled on the floor and placed her fair hand on his chest nevertheless.

Feeling Meixiu's hand on his chest, Yuan took a deep breath and proceeded to move his right hand that had been resting on his side.

Meixiu's eyes widened with shock as she witnessed Yuan's right hand lift into the air without any support, and then she watched as it approached her hand.

Before she realized it, Yuan's right hand was directly on top of her own hand.

"Not only can I see, but I can move as well..." Yuan's voice resounded a second later, snapping Meixiu out of her daze.

Chapter 455 - A Noticeable Change

"Y-You can move now...? Since when...?" Meixiu muttered in a low voice after Yuan's shocking reveal.

"To tell you the truth, my recovery started many weeks ago— even before you started playing Cultivation Online. In fact, I initially planned on keeping this a secret until I could get off the bed by myself, but I changed my mind after hearing your words just now." Yuan said.

"My words...?"

"Yes... Your voice when you congratulated me... I couldn't continue to keep it to myself after hearing it. I'm sorry for keeping it a secret for so long, but I wanted to make sure that I was actually recovering and not give you or Yu Rou false hope."

"It's okay. You don't have to apologize. I'm just glad that you're finally recovering, Yuan." Meixiu said to him in a gentle voice, feeling an indescribable feeling surging from her heart at this moment.

Unbeknownst to Meixiu at first, tears began appearing in her eyes before quickly falling down her face.

Meixiu wiped her eyes when she realized that her vision was getting blurry, and to her surprise, she was actually crying due to being overwhelmed by happiness. It was definitely a first for her.

Meixiu quickly wiped her face with her free hand while silently hoping to herself that Yuan wasn't looking at her right now.

Luckily for her, Yuan didn't have his Divine Sense activated since he could only use it for a few moments before it exhausts his spiritual energy.

A few moments later, once Meixiu calmed down a little, she asked Yuan, "How much can you move right now? Can you sit up on the bed yet?"

"Unfortunately, lifting a hand is already my limit. Any more and my body will start experiencing pain," he sighed.

"Don't push yourself, Yuan. You're recovering, and that's all it matters."

"I know."

"Are you going to tell Yu Rou?" Meixiu suddenly asked.

"..."

Yuan didn't immediately respond, and after a moment of silence, he said, "I... I want to surprise her. When I tell Yu Rou, I want to be standing. I hope you don't mind keeping this a secret for now."

"I don't mind," Meixiu said.

"Thank you."

Sometime later, Yuan said, "I am already at the peak of Spirit Warrior, but I cannot breakthrough to Spirit Master for some reason. I will try for a few more days. If I still cannot breakthrough, I will focus on Cultivation Online."

"Alright. I will try to push for the ninth level before I return to Cultivation Online." Meixiu said.

"Take your time."

Meixiu returned to her own room a few moments later.

'Yuan... He's recovering... He can see again, even move... I cannot wait to see him walk again.'

Meixiu thought to herself as she took a seat on the hard floor and began her cultivation.

To her surprise, when she cultivated, Meixiu noticed a noticeable change in her cultivation speed, as she was absorbing the spiritual energy around her at a much quicker rate than she could previously achieve— almost twice as fast.

Meixiu didn't know what was causing this phenomenon, but she welcomed it.

A few days later, Meixiu entered the ninth level of Spirit Apprentice.

"Yuan, did you manage to breakthrough?" Meixiu asked him.

"Nope..." Yuan sighed.

"Every time it feels like I am about to have a breakthrough, that feeling would suddenly disappear. It's like walking towards an open door, but just as you're about to enter that door, it closes in your face."

Meixiu pondered for a moment before speaking, "Maybe it has something to do with our world? What if there's not enough spiritual energy for you to breakthrough? Spirit Master is pretty high, right?"

"Now that you mention it... That does make sense... Okay, I will ask Xiao Hua and the others later." Yuan said.

"What about you? Have you reached your goal?" Yuan asked her.

"Yes, but the three-month time limit for the registration is getting close, so I was thinking about registering myself first so I can get it out of the way. What about you, Yuan?"

"Registering, huh? Okay, let's go register ourselves and get this over with."

"Let's do it tomorrow since it's already late today," Meixiu suggested.

Sometime later, Meixiu went to prepare dinner.

After dinner, they went to sleep, taking a break from cultivation.

The following morning after breakfast, Meixiu helped Yuan change into a more fitting outfit for their journey outside before carrying him to his wheelchair.

"Are you ready to go?" Meixiu asked him after she prepared herself.

Yuan didn't say anything, but he closed his hand into a fist before giving her a thumbs up.

A smile appeared on Meixiu's face, and she pushed the wheelchair outside, leaving the apartment with him.

"How far away is the Cultivators' Association from here?" Yuan asked her once they were downstairs.

"It's about an hour from here on foot," she said.

"Do you want to take the taxi instead?"

"I want to look at the scenery if you don't mind..."

"I'm okay. We can walk."

"Thank you, Meixiu."

"I should probably buy a car to make traveling more convenient in case we need it..." Meixiu muttered to herself shortly after they started moving.

Despite her young age, Meixiu already has a driver's license, so she was qualified to drive a car.

"A car, huh? It'll definitely be necessary if we want to go anywhere that cannot be traveled in a reasonable time on foot." Yuan said.

"Yeah, you should probably get a car." Yuan agreed with her.

"Really? What kind of car should I get?"

"Yes. You can get whatever you want. I'll let you choose."

"Okay. I'll look around after we register at the Cultivators' Association."

While they made their way towards the Cultivators' Association, Yuan would use his Divine Sense to look at his surroundings.

Although he couldn't see any further than a few meters around him, it was more than enough for someone like him who hasn't seen the world for so many years.

An hour later, they arrived at the Cultivators' Association.

"Wow, there's a lot of people here even though it's so early in the morning." Meixiu was surprised to see the crowd of people gathered there.

After taking a moment to examine the area, Meixiu approached the tall building with Yuan.

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Chapter 456 - A True Cultivation Genius

After avoiding the crowd with much effort, Meixiu pushed the wheelchair inside the building, where there were even more people, but since the people were in line in an orderly fashion, it felt much more spacious than outside.

It took a moment since there were multiple lines, but once Meixiu found the end of a line, she went there with Yuan.

While they waited in line, Yuan used his Divine Sense to look at the place and the people there.

The majority of people there were between the third level and the fifth level with a couple at the sixth level. Of course, all of them were still Spirit Apprentices.

Meixiu also looked around while they waited.

The interior of the building was quite bland, and there was barely any furniture or decoration. At the end of the room, there were a couple of desks with a clerk working behind it.

"I have been thinking, Meixiu, but how does the registration even work? Do they have some sort of device that can gauge our cultivation?" Yuan suddenly asked.

"I'm not sure, actually. I didn't really look into it. However, I don't see any devices in the front. Let me look it up real quick."

Meixiu proceeded to take out her cellphone and searched about the Cultivators' Association.

A few minutes later, she said, "According to this website, we only have to prove to them that we can cultivate in order to register as a cultivator. If we want to join the Cultivators' Association, we will need to undergo some sort of exam."

"Oh, we only need to prove to them that we can cultivate? That's easier than I'd thought." Yuan said.

They continued to wait, and after about two hours of waiting, they finally reached the front.

"How may I help you?" The woman behind the desk asked them.

"We're here to register as a cultivator," Meixiu said.

"I understand. Can I see your identification?"

"Identification?"

It was at this moment she realized that they didn't have any identification on them.

"Are identifications necessary? We didn't bring any." Meixiu said a moment later.

"If you don't have any identification on you, we will need your fingerprints. This is only to make sure that you're not a criminal or have any criminal record." The woman said to her.

"Okay, we can do that instead." Meixiu nodded.

"Great. Please scan your index finger on this."

The woman then handed her a small device that scanned fingerprints.

Meixiu placed her index finger on the device and waited until the woman spoke again, "Okay, you can take your finger off now."

"Give me a minute to run your fingerprint through the database."

Sometime later, Meixiu's information appeared on the screen.

When the woman saw that she was from the Yu Family, her eyes widened with surprise.

If she was from the Yu Family, why didn't she say so in the beginning?

Even though Meixiu and Yuan left the Yu Family, they're still technically part of the family since the Yu Family didn't remove them from the database.

"Okay, you're cleared. Please go to the room behind me for the next step."

Meixiu then said while pointing at Yuan, "We're together, and he's also here to register as a cultivator. Can we go inside together?"

"He's also a cultivator?" The woman raised her eyebrow when she saw Yuan.

"I will have to run his fingerprints as well." The woman said.

"Okay."

Meixiu proceeded to help Yuan place his finger on the device.

Sometime later, Yuan's information appeared on the screen for the woman to see.

'Yu Tian? He's also from the Yu Family! And he's even their son! I thought they only had a daughter!' The woman was shocked to see this, as she was only aware of Yu Rou's existence.

"Alright... I have cleared him as well." The woman said a moment later.

"Thank you."

Meixiu left the desk and walked to the door at the end of the hall a moment later with Yuan, which led to another large and spacious room.

The interior of this room looked like an empty gym, and there were people sitting in the lotus position near the middle of the room, absorbing the spiritual energy in the air.

A person only needed to continuously absorb spiritual energy for a minute straight to be deemed a cultivator, so the line moved relatively fast.

About half an hour later, Meixiu and Yuan reached the front of the line.

"Next!"

A bulky middle-aged man with a stopwatch turned to look at Meixiu after the previous individual left his seat.

"I will be right back, Yuan," Meixiu said as she left his side and took a seat beside the bulky man.

"Good luck," he said to her.

"I will start the time once you begin to cultivate. You must cultivate without stopping for an entire minute to qualify as a cultivator," he said to her.

Meixiu nodded and closed her eyes.

She then took a deep breath and began to recite the Divine-grade cultivation technique inside her mind.

Very quickly, the spiritual energy in the building began flying towards Meixiu, creating a small vortex around her.

"W-What the heck is that cultivation speed?!"

The bulky man and the others were shocked when they saw how quickly Meixiu was absorbing the spiritual energy.

"Heavens... She is a true cultivation genius..." The bulky man mumbled in a dazed voice as he stared at Meixiu's beautiful face, seemingly mesmerized by her.

He has been working here ever since the Cultivators' Association was created, and he has watched tens of thousands of people cultivate during the past few weeks, but none of them could compare to this young beauty cultivating before him right now.

More than a minute has passed since Meixiu started cultivating, but the bulky man didn't say anything, as he'd completely forgotten about the time when watching Meixiu cultivate.

A few more minutes later, Meixiu opened her eyes and turned to look at the bulky man.

"Excuse me, I think it's been more than a minute," she said to him in a calm voice.

"Eh?"

The bulky man quickly looked at his stopwatch, and sure enough, three minutes have passed since Meixiu started cultivating.

Chapter 457 - Chairman Zhao

"S-Sorry, I spaced out..." The bulky man said in a still dazed voice.

"You have passed the cultivation test."

Meixiu nodded and stood up.

"If you don't mind me asking, what cultivation base have you achieved?"
The bulky man suddenly asked her.

"Ninth Level Spirit Apprentice," Meixiu responded in a calm voice.

"N-Ninth level!" The bulky man trembled upon hearing this.

"Is there anything else?" Meixiu then asked him.

"N-No..." he quickly shook his head.

However, just as Meixiu started walking back to Yuan, a loud voice suddenly resounded, causing everyone to turn to look at the source.

"Wait a second, young lady!"

At the end of the hall, an old man followed by four other individuals could be seen approaching them in a hurry.

"C-Chairman!" The bulky man exclaimed when he saw this old man, and he quickly lowered his head to bow.

'Who?' Meixiu wondered inwardly as they approached her.

"Hello, young lady. My name is Zhao Zheng, and I am the chairman of the Cultivators' Association. I saw your cultivation just now, and it left me in awe. Can I get your name?"

"Meixiu," she responded.

"Then, Lady Meixiu, would you like to join my Cultivators' Association? We are currently in need of talented cultivators, and you're exactly what we are looking for. If you join us, we can guarantee you a Heaven-grade cultivation technique, and when we acquire a Divine-grade cultivation technique in the future, you will also get to practice it." Zhao Zheng said, trying to recruit Meixiu into the Cultivators' Association.

However, Meixiu quickly shook her head and said, "Thank you for the offer, but I do not wish to join the Cultivators' Association."

The spectators were shocked when Meixiu refused Zhao Zheng's offer so casually. Many of them had plans to join the Cultivators' Association after this, so when they saw Meixiu getting recruited by the chairman of the association, they were overwhelmed with jealousy.

"What! The chairman himself personally invited you to join the Cultivators' Association and you dare refuse?! Know your place!" One of the figures standing behind Zhao Zheng suddenly exclaimed.

Another one then said, "You may have some talents in cultivation, but without a proper cultivation technique, you can only go so far. However, if you join us, we can guarantee you a limitless future."

Despite their words, Meixiu remained calm and said, "I refuse."

"You—!"

"Stop." Zhao Zheng suddenly interrupted.

Once there was silence, he continued, "Can you at least tell me why you're refusing my offer? Are you already part of another power? Or do you have something against our association?"

"I have nothing against the association. My hands are already fully occupied with other matters, and I'm not interested in the Cultivators' Association in general." Meixiu said.

"Other matters? There's nothing my association cannot solve. If you join us, we'll help you with whatever you're occupied with." Zhao Zheng wasn't willing to give up someone as talented as Meixiu so easily.

Hearing his words, Meixiu smiled and said, "No thank you. I enjoy what I am doing, and I will continue doing it until I am no longer needed."

"What a pity." Zhao Zheng shook his head.

He then said, "Well, if you ever decide to change your mind, my Cultivators' Association will always have its doors opened for you."

Zhao Zheng turned around and walked away without saying anything else. The four people with him lingered for a little longer to stare at Meixiu with displeased looks on their faces before leaving with Zhao Zheng.

Once the place returned to being somewhat peaceful, the bulky man could finally breathe properly, and he continued the examination shortly after.

"Young lady, you're going the wrong way." The bulky man said to Meixiu when he noticed her returning to the line.

He then pointed at the door on the other side and continued, "If you're finished, you go to that room."

"I didn't come alone," she said to him.

Meixiu then walked to Yuan and began pushing his wheelchair.

"He's with me, and he's also here to register," she said.

"He's also a cultivator?" The bulky man raised his eyebrows when he saw Yuan.

This is his first time seeing someone in a wheelchair registering as a cultivator.

As they approached the bulky man, Meixiu whispered to Yuan, "I think you should keep it low-key. I don't want those people coming back to bother you. They're definitely a troublesome bunch. I can only imagine what will happen if they see your real talents."

"I know. I'll restrain myself." Yuan said.

Meanwhile, after they left the test room, Zhao Zheng didn't actually leave and stayed behind to continue watching Meixiu.

"Do we have any information on that girl?" He asked the four behind him.

One of them pulled out his phone and said, "According to the clerk that spoke with them, she's a servant from the Yu Family. They're a powerhouse in the entertainment industry."

"What about that young man in a wheelchair? How is he related to her?"

"He's also from the Yu Family— their son. That girl is probably his caretaker or something."

"I see..."

Back in the other room, the bulky man said, "Whenever you're ready."

Yuan took a deep breath and began to absorb the spiritual energy in the room, making sure to keep things to a minimum by imitating the cultivation speed of other cultivators that went before him.

When Zhao Zheng saw Yuan's abysmal cultivating speed when compared to Meixiu, he sneered in a cold voice, "She's throwing away her talents for that trash? Ridiculous!"

After a moment of silence, he said, "Get the Yu Family on the line and tell them that I would like a meeting with them! I am not going to let such a talented cultivator go to waste for that useless thing!"

"Right away, Chairman Zhao."

The person proceeded to look for the Yu Family's contact information before dialing their number.

A minute later, the bulky man said, "Alright. You passed."

"Go through those doors to complete your registration."

Meixiu nodded and left the room with Yuan shortly after.

—

There is a new voting system for FreeWebNovel called Golden Tickets for the premium novels that will reset once a month. You can get them through spending coins or gifting the novel a certain amount(500+). If you don't have this in your app, update the app.

Therefore, in order to bribe you into voting, I shall give you THREE bonus chapters(including daily chapters) for both Dual Cultivation and Cultivation Online if Hero's Carnage, my new novel, reaches 1,000 Golden Tickets.

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Chapter 458 - Meeting With The Yu Family

"Hello, can I get your names?" A clerk working behind the desk asked Meixiu when she approached him with Yuan.

"Meixiu and Yu Tian," she said.

"Okay, give me a minute to create your identifications."

The clerk then looked up their information before creating an identification card with it.

"I just need a picture of your face now." The clerk then said.

Meixiu went first, taking a headshot by standing in front of the camera on the desk.

Yuan went next.

Once they both took a picture, the clerk printed it on their identification card before handing it to them.

"Here you go. You're done."

"Thank you."

Meixiu accepted the cards and left the building shortly after.

"That was easier than I'd expected," Yuan said afterward.

"Yes. Besides that little recruitment, it went much smoother than I'd expected."

Meixiu then said, "Let's go home now that we no longer have to worry about it."

"Alright."

After returning to the apartment, Meixiu helped Yuan take a quick shower before changing his clothes.

"We're going to play Cultivation Online again starting tomorrow, right? Let's call Yu Rou and see if she wants to play with us." Yuan said.

"Okay, let me try to call her now."

Meixiu retrieved her phone and called Yu Rou.

However, Yu Rou didn't answer the phone in time, and it went to her voicemail.

"She's probably busy. I will try again later—"

Meixiu stopped talking when her phone began ringing.

"Oh? It's Yu Rou."

Meixiu quickly answered the phone.

"Sorry, I was just finishing up my registration at the Cultivators' Association." Yu Rou said.

"You also went to register at the association today? We just came back from that place."

"What? Really? What a pity that we didn't meet." Yu Rou sighed out loud.

"Anyways, do you need something?"

"Yes, we plan on playing Cultivation Online again starting tomorrow. Yuan asked if you want to play together."

"Of course!" Yu Rou quickly said.

"Where are you located? We'll come to you."

Yu Rou then gave Meixiu her location.

"Okay, we will see you there tomorrow," Meixiu said afterward.

"Yup!"

After hanging up, Meixiu said, "Yu Rou said she'll play with us. She's also at a place called Seashell City."

"Great."

Yuan proceeded to spend the rest of the day trying to breakthrough to Spirit Master.

Meanwhile, at the Yu Family's main house, Yu Yong and Tang Lee sat before an old man.

"How can we help you, Chairman Zhao?" Yu Yong asked him.

"Thank you for seeing me on such short notice, Yu Family." Chairman Zhao said, and then he placed a small box on the table.

"Accept this compensation from me."

Yu Yong accepted the box without even opening it.

"Thank you."

Chairman Zhao took a deep breath before speaking, "Anyways, I have come here today regarding someone from your family."

Yu Yong frowned slightly upon hearing this, wondering if someone from his family had offended the Chairman of the Cultivators' Association.

"She's a servant from your family, and I believe her name is Meixiu."
Chairman Zhao then revealed Meixiu's name.

"What? Meixiu?" Yu Yong's eyes widened.

"Did she do something?" he then asked.

"Haha... No, she didn't. She was at the Cultivators' Association today to register as a cultivator, and I was impressed by her cultivation talents. I wanted her to join my Cultivators' Association, but she refused, so I was hoping you could do something about it."

"The Chairman is impressed by Meixiu's talents? Really?" Yu Yong was in disbelief after hearing this.

"Yes. In terms of talents, she's definitely one of the best I have personally seen. Furthermore, she even claimed to be a Ninth Level Spirit Apprentice."

"Ninth level?! That's impossible!" Tang Lee exclaimed. She has only reached the sixth level even with her Heaven-grade cultivation technique. How could a servant who ran away from home reach the ninth level? With what cultivation technique?

"I know it's hard to believe, but if you saw her cultivation speed..."
Chairman Zhao said.

"I am willing to negotiate— No, I will buy Meixiu from the Yu Family. How much do you want?" Chairman Zhao then asked.

"Ehh..."

Yu Yong exchanged surprised looks with Tang Lee.

After a moment of silence, he said, "I'm sorry, Chairman Zhao, but I'm afraid that's not possible right now."

"What do you mean by that?" Chairman Zhao frowned.

"Meixiu... She's actually no longer part of the Yu Family, as she decided to leave the family a few months ago." Yu Yong said.

"What?" Chairman Zhao sat there with a baffled look on his face.

"Then do you know where she is currently?"

Yu Yong shook his head.

"Unfortunately, we don't. Maybe her mother or my daughter knows something. I can ask them right now."

"Please do." Chairman Zhao nodded.

"Alright. Give me a few minutes."

Yu Yong proceeded to take out his cellphone to call Meifeng.

"Meifeng, do you know where your daughter, Meixiu, is currently staying?" Yu Yong asked her after she answered the phone.

After a moment of silence, Meifeng responded, "I'm sorry, but she didn't tell me anything. I have tried calling her before, but she didn't pick up."

"Then do you have any idea where she might have gone?"

"I do not."

"I see... Thank you."

"Umm... If you don't mind me asking, why are you looking for Meixiu?" Meifeng suddenly asked.

"Chairman Zhao from the Cultivators' Association would like to speak with her, so if you see her or hear anything, let me know."

"I understand. I will let the Masters know if I hear from her." Meifeng said.

Yu Yong hung up shortly after and proceeded to call Yu Rou.

"Huh? Do I know where Meixiu went? No, I don't. Why do you ask?" Yu Rou responded in a casual voice after hearing her father's question.

"Are you sure you don't know?" Yu Yong asked again. "Don't you have her contact information? You mean to tell me that you haven't spoken to her since she left? I don't believe it."

"I don't know what to tell you, father. I really don't know anything, but I can try calling her later."

"Okay. Let me know if you learn anything." Yu Yong said before hanging up.

He then returned to Chairman Zhao and said, "I apologize, but it seems like nobody knows her location. However, we'll try looking for her. If we find anything, we'll let you know."

Although Chairman Zhao was unhappy about the results, there was nothing he could do about it.

"I understand. Thank you for trying. Here's my business card. Call me if you find her." Chairman Zhao left his business card on the table before leaving the place.

Once Chairman Zhao was gone, Tang Lee said, "Unbelievable... To think Meixiu was a cultivation genius that even the Chairman of the Cultivators' Association would go through such trouble to recruit."

"We need to find her, or we might risk offending the Cultivators' Association," she added.

Yu Yong nodded, "I agree. I will call some people that specialize in finding people now."

Meanwhile, after her phone call with Yu Yong ended, Meifeng dialed Meixiu's number.

"Mother?" Meixiu quickly answered.

"Be careful, Meixiu. I don't know why, but the Chairman of the Cultivators' Association is looking for you." Meifeng wanted her.

"What?" Meixiu was surprised to hear this. The Chairman still hasn't given up on her?

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Chapter 459 - Please Carry Me

"Did something happen?" Meixiu asked her.

"That's what I want to ask you. What happened? Did you offend the Chairman? Why would someone like him be searching for you?" Meifeng asked her.

"Well..." Meixiu proceeded to explain to her mother what had occurred at the Cultivators' Association today.

Meifeng remained silent for a good moment after hearing Meixiu's story, and all she said at the end was—

"Just be careful and refrain from going outside for a while. Chairman Zhao is a powerful man who is at the top of the Cultivators' Association. He may not be a powerful cultivator, but he has plenty of influence and more than enough people to suppress you."

"I understand. Thank you for the warning."

"Don't you get it, Meixiu? If you're in danger, the Young Master will also be in danger. Whatever you do, just make sure you protect him."

"You don't need to tell me that," Meixiu said.

Meifeng hung up the phone shortly after.

"Haaa..." Meixiu sighed out loud.

However, before she could even think about the situation, her phone began ringing again.

It was Yu Rou.

Meixiu answered the phone but didn't say anything.

"Meixiu? Are you okay? My father is looking for you for some reason." Yu Rou's voice then resounded.

Meixiu released a sigh of relief after hearing Yu Rou's voice, and she said, "Yes, I am fine."

"As for what happened..."

After Yu Rou heard the story, she exclaimed in an angry voice, "What?! How shameless! You have already refused to join the Cultivators' Association, yet they're still pursuing you?! They even went out of their way to visit my parents! I cannot believe that there are people like them out there!"

"It is what it is. There's no point getting angry about it, as it won't change anything." Meixiu said.

"What do you plan on doing? I doubt the Cultivators' Association would give up on you."

"I don't know yet, but I will think of something."

"Alright. If you need anything, call me, okay?"

"I will. See you tomorrow." Meixiu said.

After hanging up, Meixiu went to Yuan's room and explained to him the situation.

"What a pain in the ass. Now I regret going to register." Yuan sighed out loud.

"What do you think we should do?" Meixiu asked him.

"I don't think there's anything we can do besides hope that they give up on you. After all, they have the entire Cultivators' Association behind them while we're just two people who ran away from their family." Yuan said.

"Should we relocate just in case?" Meixiu then asked.

"Wouldn't that just attract their attention? Judging by what Miss Meifeng and Yu Rou said, they don't know your location yet, so it's probably better if we stay put here."

"I will try to think of something, but that's all I can think of for now."

"Okay." Meixiu nodded.

Sometime later, Meixiu returned to her room and tried to sleep since she wasn't in the mood to cultivate.

However, Yuan decided to enter Cultivation Online.

"Young Master? It's rare seeing you during the night. Did something happen?" Feng Yuxiang asked him, as he usually doesn't return until morning.

"Something like that." Yuan nodded.

"Is there anything we can do to help?" Xiao Hua then asked.

"Unfortunately, no..."

He then said, "Feng Feng, do you remember when I asked you if you know any doctors?"

"Yes, but I haven't been able to sense that person yet, and he never stays in one place for long, so I have no idea where he is. Why do you need to see him so suddenly?" Feng Yuxiang said.

After a moment of silence, he said, "My friend... He's sick, and I need him to heal as soon as possible. Although he's recovering... he's not recovering not fast enough."

"I see... Okay, I will see what I can do." Feng Yuxiang came out of his body and continued, "I will go ask around and see if I can find him."

Yuan nodded, "Thank you, Feng Feng. I will be meeting my sister tomorrow at Seashell City. We probably won't go far."

"Don't worry, Young Master. I will be able to find you as long as you're still in the Lower Heavens." Feng Yuxiang said.

"I will return as soon as possible, Young Master."

"Yes, see you soon."

Feng Yuxiang flew away shortly after.

Xiao Hua appeared beside him after Feng Yuxiang left, and she asked him, "Are you really okay, Brother Yuan?"

Yuan took a deep breath before sighing out loud, "I... I hate feeling powerless. Even though my friend is in trouble, I cannot do anything about it—I really hate that feeling."

Xiao Hua wasn't sure what to say, as this is her first time seeing Yuan acting this gloomy.

"You're not powerless, my Lord. Even if you feel helpless, you have us. I'm sure we'll figure something out." Lan Yingying said to him.

"Thank you, Yingying," Yuan said to her with a slight smile, feeling a little better.

Sometime later, he said to them before logging off, "I will see you guys tomorrow morning."

"Goodnight, my Lord."

"See you later, Brother Yuan."

Once he logged off, Yuan proceeded to spend the rest of the night trying to breakthrough to Spirit Master, but alas, it didn't work.

The following morning, after breakfast, Yuan and Meixiu logged into the game and made their way to Seashell City to meet up with Yu Rou.

"Eh? Feng Feng went somewhere last night?" Meixiu was surprised to hear this.

Who will carry her now?

"I can carry you if you don't mind," Yuan suddenly said to her.

"Or are you still not ready for it?" He remembered what she said before.

"Uhh..."

Meixiu wasn't sure how to respond.

However, the scene of Xuan Wuhan kissing Yuan on the cheeks suddenly flashed into her mind.

Meixiu gritted her teeth for a moment before nodding her head with a resolute look on her face.

"Please carry me," she said with a rosy face.

After getting her approval, Yuan retrieved the flying sword before carrying Meixiu in his arms like a princess.

The next moment, Yuan jumped on the sword and soared towards the sky with Xiao Hua by his side, leaving Long Chen City in a flash.

Chapter 460 - Snowy

Four hours after they left Long Chen City, Yuan and the others finally arrived at Seashell City. During their whole ride, Meixiu would try her best to avoid eye contact with Yuan, but it was nearly impossible, and every time she glanced at his handsome face that was only a few inches away from her own, she would immediately begin blushing.

They descended a couple of miles away from the city to avoid getting too much attention.

Once they landed, Yuan placed Meixiu back onto the ground before removing his mask.

"You're going to remove your mask?" Meixiu asked him.

He nodded and said, "I had to wear a mask in the sect because the players knew I was there and were actively searching for me, but now that I am no longer there, nobody will be able to recognize me as long as I don't do anything too crazy."

"I should also change out of the Golden Dragon Robe since it's quite attractive as well."

Yuan proceeded to change his clothes on the spot, replacing the Golden Dragon Robe with the plain clothes he first wore when he started playing Cultivation Online, as it looked the most simple.

"I should probably buy some casual clothes..." Yuan mumbled to himself afterward.

"Hmm? What's up, Xiao Hua?" Yuan noticed Xiao Hua staring at him and decided to ask her.

"Brother Yuan, when did your hair grow so long?" Xiao Hua said, as she'd just realized his new appearance.

"Oh, it was caused by some treasure Feng Feng gave me. I think it was called a Longevity Seed. Does it look weird?"

Xiao Hua shook her head and said, "It's not weird. Brother Yuan resembles a cultivator even more now."

Sometime later, after Yuan finished changing, they began making their way towards the city.

"Yu—"

Yuan easily picked out Yu Rou's figure despite the crowd gathered outside the city, but right as he prepared to call her, he suddenly closed his mouth.

After a moment of silence, he said, "Who's that girl beside Yu Rou? They appear to be together."

"Let me see..." Meixiu narrowed her eyes and looked at the beautiful girl standing beside Yu Rou.

"Oh, that's Xia Jingyi, Yu Rou's classmate."

"Xia Jingyi? The one who allowed me to live in her parents' apartment?" Yuan asked.

"Yes."

"I see... So that's what she looks like..." Yuan nodded with a focused expression, seemingly interested in her.

Meixiu raised her eyebrows at his reaction.

Of course, Yuan was only interested in her because he believed that he was indebted to her, who gave him a place to live when he was struggling to find a new home.

"Yu Rou!" Yuan called out to her again.

When Yu Rou heard Yuan's voice, she immediately turned to look at him, and a bright smile appeared on her face the next second.

"Brother!"

Yu Rou ran to him with her arms spread.

Yuan gladly welcomed her into his embrace.

"It's been a while, Yu Rou."

"It's been longer than just a while. It feels like forever since I last saw you," she said.

"H-Hello." Xia Jingyi greeted him in a somewhat bashful voice after catching up to Yu Rou.

"Brother, this is—"

Yuan turned to look at Xia Jingyi and smiled, "I know. You are Xia Jingyi, right? Let me thank you again for letting me stay in your parents' apartment. Thank you."

She didn't say anything and only nodded.

"I hope you don't mind letting her join us. We've been playing Cultivation Online together this entire time, and it would be rude to exclude her." Yu Rou then said.

"Of course I wouldn't mind it. You can join us whenever you want." Yuan said.

"T-Thank you."

"There's no need to be so shy, Jingyi. It's not like this is your first meeting. Look, even Meixiu is here." Yu Rou said to her.

"I-I know, but I can't help it... You know that I'm not good with men..." Xia Jingyi said.

"You'll have to get used to it if you want to come with us. I'm sure you'll be okay."

"I will try..." she nodded.

"Hello, Xiao Hua. It's been a while." Yu Rou didn't forget about her and greeted her.

"Hello."

Yu Rou then looked around and asked, "Where's Feng Feng? I don't see her."

"She's currently busy with something so she won't be with us," Yuan said.

"I see..."

Sometime later, Yu Rou asked, "What should we do now?"

Yuan shrugged and said, "I don't really have a plan since I only thought about spending time with you. What do you two usually do?"

"Well... We normally hunt monsters together and do repeatable quests."

"What about your cultivation levels?"

"I am at the second level of Spirit Warrior while Jingyi is at the first level." Yu Rou said.

"I see..."

Yuan began pondering.

Then he recalled something, "What about the Spirit Fruit you got from Feng Feng? Have you obtained a servant yet?"

Hearing his question, Yu Rou suddenly smiled and said, "I'm glad you asked, brother! Feast your eyes on my servant! Come out, Snowy!"

"Snowy?" Yuan raised his eyebrows at this weird name.

The next moment, a small, four-legged creature covered in white fur appeared before them.

"This is... a dog?" Yuan wasn't exactly sure what this creature was so he took a guess.

"Wrong! Snowy is a tiger cub... I think!" Yu Rou said.

And she continued, "We met Snowy during one of our quests near a mountain range. She was being chased by a large bear at that time, and we rescued it. After that, I gave her the Spirit Fruit because I found her really cute, and the rest is history!"

"Also, don't be surprised when you hear this, but Snowy is actually a Heaven-grade servant!" Yu Rou said a moment later.

"What? Really?" Yuan looked at the small white creature with a somewhat surprised look on his face, wondering how this small thing could possibly be a Heaven-grade servant.

Suddenly, Xiao Hua approached them and said, "This cub is a Spiritual Beast."

"A what?" Everybody there turned to look at her with wide eyes.

Chapter 461 - Spiritual Beast

"What's a Spiritual Beast? That sounds powerful." Yu Rou asked Xiao Hua.

"They are magical beasts... but naturally more powerful, just like Divine Beasts. However, they're not quite as powerful as Divine Beasts. There's also a chance that a Spiritual Beast can evolve into a Divine Beast." Xiao Hua said.

She looked at the tiger cub and said, "It's very rare to find a Spiritual Beast this young since they're usually with their parents, and for you to make it into your servant... You got incredibly lucky."

Yu Rou picked up the ball of fluff and hugged it. "Hehe... I knew she was special the moment I saw her, but I didn't think she was this special. I really lucked out!"

Xiao Hua nodded and said, "That's why you should keep her hidden unless you absolutely need her. There are people out there who would steal others' servants out of jealousy, especially if they are rare creatures."

"What?! Really? How does that work? Stealing another individual's servant." Yu Rou asked.

"If the Master dies, the contract will naturally end. Though there are methods to forcefully sever a contract without killing the Master." Xiao Hua said.

"That sounds scary..." Yu Rou said.

Then she called Snowy back just in case.

"There shouldn't be many people who can recognize a Spiritual Beast in the Lower Heavens since they are so rare, but you should still be careful."

"I understand. Thank you, Xiao Hua." Yu Rou nodded.

"Does it have any special abilities?" Yuan suddenly asked her.

"Nope. The only thing she can do is bite, but she's too small to even fight effectively." Yu Rou said.

Then she turned to look at Xiao Hua and asked, "Is there any way to make Spiritual Beasts grow faster? I will have to look for another servant if it's going to take a few years before I can let Snowy fight."

Xiao Hua nodded and said, "Yes, there are treasures that can speed up a magical beast's growth, but they are incredibly rare."

"Great! I will keep that in mind." Yu Rou said.

Sometime later, Yuan said, "Let's do some quests together. You two can pick."

"Are you sure? The quests may be too easy for you." Yu Rou said.

"I don't mind. I just want to spend time with you."

"Okay. Then let's go look for some quests."

Sometime later, they entered the city and asked around to see whether there was any quest they could do.

After about an hour of looking, they accepted a quest that required them to gather some material that can only be obtained from a certain magical beast.

"The Black Horn Bull can be found at the Orange Field. They're around the seventh level of Spirit Apprentice. I will need as many horns as you can gather, and I will pay 10 gold coins for each horn." A middle-aged man said to them before handing them a map.

"I understand. We should return soon." Yu Rou said.

After leaving the place, Yu Rou said, "According to the map, the Orange Land is quite far away. It's going to take us around 10 hours to get there if we walk. However, if we travel by horses or carriages, it'll be much quicker."

"Carriages?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

He then said, "I have never ridden in a carriage before. Let's try that out."

"Okay!"

"Where do we ride carriages?" Yuan then asked.

"There's a store that rents horses with carriage service. Let's go there." Yu Rou said.

Yu Rou proceeded to lead them to this store.

Ten minutes later, they arrived before a large building that had almost a dozen horses on display, and there were even a couple of carriages in the back.

"Hello, I would like to purchase the carriage service." Yu Rou approached the reception desk and asked the middle-aged man managing it.

"Sure thing, young lady. Where are you guys trying to go? And is it going to be a one-way trip or a round-trip?"

"The Orange Lands. Round-trip."

"Orange Lands, huh? Alright, give me a moment to do some calculations."

A moment later, he continued, "That would be 3 gold coins for the ordinary service and 10 gold coins for the premium service."

"What's the difference?" Yuan asked.

"The ordinary service will provide you... well, an ordinary horse and an average carriage. You will also have to drive the carriage by yourself. The premium service provides a faster horse, a larger carriage, and even a driver for the carriage for a better experience overall."

"We'll take the premium service," said Yu Rou.

"Alright. That'll be 10 gold coins."

Yu Rou nodded and handed 10 gold coins to the manager.

"Thank you for choosing us, young lady. Give me about ten minutes to find you a driver. If you have any preferences for the driver, let me know. We even have cultivators who can drive the carriage as well as guards if you need them. However, that will cost additional fees."

"An ordinary driver is fine." Yu Rou said.

After all, they had Yuan, who was infinitely stronger than any guard they could provide.

"I understand."

The manager disappeared for some time before returning, "Your carriage is ready. Please follow me."

Yu Rou and the others followed the manager to the outside, where a decorated carriage and a horse were waiting in the street.

Yuan looked at the square-shaped carriage with awe, as this is his first time seeing a carriage in this fashion.

A few moments later, they entered the carriage, but there was only room for 4 people. Any more and it'll become a little cramped.

"Here, Xiao Hua. I will make some room for you." Yuan said when everyone was seated beside her.

"It's okay. Xiao Hua will sit here."

Xiao Hua said before entering the carriage and taking a seat on Yuan's l.a.p.

"Is it okay?" she asked him afterward.

"I don't mind." Yuan nodded.

When Yu Rou saw this, she had an idea.

"Snowy, come out."

Once the white ball of fluff returned, Yu Rou had it sit on her l.a.p while she hugged it.

"Are we ready to move?" The driver asked them a moment later.

"Yes!" Yu Rou said.

"Then I shall start moving the carriage now. Hah!"

The driver said before commanding the horses to move, pulling the carriage along with it.

Chapter 462 - Magical Beasts

Blocking the Road

After the carriage left the city, the driver spoke in a loud voice, "We should arrive at Orange Lands in three hours if we don't get attacked by wild magical beasts."

"Okay! Thank you!" Yu Rou responded in a loud voice.

Meanwhile, Yuan had his head turned to look outside the window. Riding in a carriage felt like they were riding a slow car that was also quite bumpy, yet there was a distinct difference that made riding a carriage much more enjoyable.

"Brother, I just noticed this, but when did your hair grow so long? I don't think my hair has grown since I started playing..." Yu Rou suddenly asked him.

Since she was used to Yuan having long hair in the real world, she didn't immediately notice it.

"Oh, I ate a treasure that regrew my hair and made it longer. Feng Feng and Xiao Hua said it looked good, so I decided to leave it like this," he said.

"I agree with them. You look very handsome! Don't you think so too, Jingyi?" Yu Rou asked her.

"Eh? Why are you asking me...?" She quickly began flustering.

Sometime later, Yu Rou asked, "Brother, what have you two been doing recently? Are you doing okay living by yourselves?"

Yuan nodded, "Yes, we're doing fine. As for what we've been doing recently... besides cultivation, nothing else really."

"I-If you have any problems with the apartment, please let me know... I will call someone to fix it." Xia Jingyi said to him.

"Oh, right. I know you said we can live there for free, but I don't want to feel like a freeloader. Please allow me to pay for the rent."

"Are you sure? The rent is not cheap there if I have to be honest with you..."

"Yes, I am sure. We have made enough money by selling in-game items. If we need more, we can sell more items." Yuan said.

After a moment of silence, Xia Jingyi nodded, "Okay, if you insist on paying the rent, I will tell the apartment manager to send you the bill every month starting the next month."

"Okay."

About an hour later, the carriage came to a sudden stop, and the driver shouted, "Esteemed guests! There's a pack of dark wolves blocking the road ahead!"

"Dark wolves, huh? Let me take care of it!" Yu Rou eagerly left the carriage and retrieved her fan—the same one that Yuan bought for her.

She then walked to the front of the carriage and approached the group of dark wolves with a brave expression on her face.

Yuan peeked his head out the window to look at the dark wolves.

They were all between the level of 3rd level and 5th level Spirit Apprentice. It was nothing Yu Rou couldn't handle as a Spirit Warrior even if they were in a group.

[Wind Blades!]

Whoosh!

The pack of dark wolves was instantly dismembered by the powerful wind blades that were as sharp as real swords.

After killing the magical beasts in a single attack, Yu Rou used wind blades again to clean up the road.

"The road is free again." Yu Rou said to the dumbfounded carriage driver.

"T-T-Thank you for your efforts, esteemed fairy!" The driver stood up and bowed to her in a respectful manner after witnessing her effortlessly kill a dozen magical beasts.

Once she returned to the carriage, Yu Rou rubbed her nose in a prideful manner and said, "Did you see that, brother? I have gotten much better with the technique."

"Yes, I saw it very clearly. You have definitely gotten a lot stronger, especially with that technique." Yuan said with a smile on her face.

"Well... It's the only offensive technique I have so I use it all the time, allowing me to master it very quickly." Yu Rou said.

It was at this moment that Yuan recalled something— that he'd get some cultivation techniques for her.

"Ah! I completely forgot to get you new techniques! Even though we went to the Myriad of Techniques... What a blunder..." Yuan sighed.

"It's okay. We can look for them later. I'm not in a hurry to look for new techniques, anyway." Yu Rou said.

"Alright."

About half an hour later, another magical beast blocked the road.

Of course, Yu Rou went outside to take care of it again.

Ten minutes later, the carriage stopped again.

"Why are there so many magical beasts blocking the road? Is it always like this? It's like they're doing this on purpose just to mess with us!" Yu Rou was beginning to get tired of them after stopping for the tenth time.

"It's common because many people travel this road every day, and magical beasts come here to find food. This is why nobody dares to travel without any guards unless they're a powerful cultivator." Xiao Hua said to her.

"However, magical beasts aren't the only thing people have to worry about, as bandits and thieves would often target people, too."

"I hope we don't run into any bandits... I'm already overwhelmed by the magical beasts." Yu Rou sighed.

"I can take care of the magical beasts if you're tired," Yuan said to her.

"I'm not physically tired, but it does feel repetitive and boring."

"It's alright. I will take care of the magical beasts now."

"Okay." Yu Rou nodded.

Sometime later, the carriage stopped again.

"Magical beasts!" The driver warned.

Yuan activated his Divine Sense and expanded it until he could see the magical beasts.

Once he located them, he retrieved his invisible Starry Abyss and controlled it to clean out the magical beasts without stepping out of the carriage.

The carriage driver was shocked when he saw this, as he was unable to comprehend the scene before him. In his eyes, the magical beasts blocking the road were being slaughtered by an invisible force.

In just a moment, all of the magical beasts were killed, clearing the road once again.

"Brother? Why are you just sitting there? Aren't you going to take care of the magical beasts?" Yu Rou asked him.

"Huh? I have already taken care of them." Yuan said in a calm voice, dumbfounding Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi.

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Author's Note: There is a new voting system for called Golden Tickets for the premium novels that will reset once a month. You can get them through spending coins or gifting the novel a certain amount(500+). If you don't have this in your app, update the app.

Therefore, in order to bribe you into voting, I shall give you THREE bonus chapters(including daily chapters) for both Dual Cultivation and Cultivation Online if Hero's Carnage, my new novel, reaches 1,000 Golden Tickets.

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Chapter 463 - Internal Destruction

"What? You've taken care of the magical beasts already? How is that even possible?" Yu Rou said.

Then she peeked her head outside the carriage window to look at the front.

"W-What?!" Yu Rou exclaimed in a shocked voice the very next moment, startling Xia Jingyi.

"What happened?!" Xia Jingyi asked her.

"T-The magical beasts on the road have all been killed!" Yu Rou said.

She pulled her head back inside the carriage before turning to look at Yuan with a look of disbelief on her face.

"H-How did you do that? What did you do?" she asked him.

Yuan lifted his palms and removed the camouflage that kept the Starry Abyss invisible, revealing to them the secret.

Yu Rou looked at the beautiful black dagger hovering above Yuan's palm and said, "Wait a minute... I have seen that dagger before. You used it to remove materials from magical beasts before!"

"Yes, and I can control it without needing to wield it, allowing me to attack from a distance. It's very convenient."

"Wow... As expected of you, brother..." Yu Rou mumbled in a low voice, her eyes filled with admiration.

Xia Jingyi was also impressed by his prowess as well, and she wondered what cultivation level he was at, but she was too shy to ask him, so she could only imagine it inside her mind.

Sometime later, the carriage began moving again after the driver snapped out of his daze.

And for the rest of the journey, Yuan would take care of the magical beasts before they could even reach the road.

About three hours after they left Seashell City, their carriage finally arrived at the Orange Lands.

"Wow, no wonder why they named this place the 'Orange' Lands. There's so much orange color in this place..." Yuan mumbled as he admired the orange scenery.

From the grass to the trees and the flowers, they were all orange in color, almost like this place was experiencing autumn while the rest of the world was in a different season.

"Do you know where are the Black Horn Bulls?" Yu Rou asked the driver.

He nodded and pointed to the wilderness in the distance and said, "You can find them a few miles in that direction. I will be stationed here until tomorrow or until you're all ready to return to the city."

"Alright. Thank you."

Sometime later, Yu Rou and the others followed the driver's directions and disappeared into the distance.

Once they were inside the orange wilderness, Yuan said, "Xiao Hua, can you look for the Black Horn Bulls for us with your Divine Sense? Mine is still too weak to search for them efficiently."

"Sure thing, Brother Yuan," she said.

"What?" Xia Jingyi raised her eyebrows after hearing Xiao Hua's words.

Did she just call him 'Yuan'?

It was at this moment that Yuan realized that Xia Jingyi wasn't aware of his identity and that he didn't tell Xiao Hua to not call him 'Yuan', as he wasn't prepared for Xia Jingyi's presence.

Meixiu and Yu Rou also realized this, but they couldn't think of any good excuses to make so quickly.

'Xiao Hua, call me Brother Yu Tian!' Yuan quickly used his Divine Sense to speak with Xiao Hua.

"B-Brother Yu Tian?" Xiao Hua said.

When Xia Jingyi heard this, she thought to herself, 'Oh, so I really heard it wrong... Their names sound kind of similar, too.'

After all, there was no way that Yu Rou's brother would be that famous Player Yuan.

'Hopefully, she didn't find out...' Yuan sighed inwardly.

However, he then wondered to himself, 'Wait... Do I really need to hide my identity from her? I think she's trustworthy enough to know about my identity...'

But it was a little late since he's already tried to hide his identity from her.

A moment later, Xiao Hua said, "Brother Yua— Yu Tian, there's a couple of Black Horn Bull half a mile in that direction."

"Okay, let's go."

They started moving in the direction that Xiao Hua pointed towards.

About ten minutes later, they stopped moving.

"Wow, there's so many of them— at least a dozen. How should we take care of them?" Yu Rou asked.

"I can kill them with the Starry Abyss, but I doubt you'd want me to do that..." Yuan said.

"That's right, brother. If you do everything for us, it wouldn't be fun. We're here for the experience, after all."

Then she said, "I am going to use wind blades to take out as many as I can. Jingyi, you'll take care of the ones that I miss."

"Okay." Xiao Jingyi nodded her head before taking a seat on the ground and retrieving a familiar-looking object from her spatial ring.

"That's... a zither? You can play the zither?" Yuan was surprised to see Xia Jingyi pull out a zither.

"Yes." Xia Jingyi said as she placed the zither on her l.a.p.

And she continued, "The zither is similar to some of the instruments I play, so I picked it as my main weapon."

"We can talk about this later. Let's deal with the Black Horn Bulls for now before they notice us or run away." Yu Rou said to them.

"Are you ready?" She then asked Xia Jingyi.

"I am."

"Good, then let me begin!"

After taking a deep breath, Yu Rou began fanning her fan many times in quick succession, sending out many wind blades at the herd of Black Horn Bulls that were eating the orange grass on the ground.

The wind blades went straight through the trees that blocked their path, knocking them down.

In just a few moments, Yu Rou had slain a little over half of the magical beasts.

When the other Black Horn Bulls saw this, they immediately stopped eating and pointed their pointy black horns in their direction.

"Jingyi, they are coming!" Yu Rou warned her.

"Got it!"

Xia Jingyi then pulled the strings on the zither with spiritual energy applied to her fingers and the zither itself.

The next second, many ripples began appearing in the area.

"Wow... What kind of technique is that? This is my first time seeing it." Yuan asked her afterward.

"It's an Earth-grade zither technique that allows me to attack my targets internally," she said.

"What? That sounds overpowered, attacking them internally... Doesn't this mean you can easily defeat all of your enemies?" Yuan said.

"Not really. My attacks can easily be repelled if someone has enough spiritual energy protecting their body. Also, it doesn't have much of a range, so I can only use it when I am close to them with someone protecting me..."

She then said, "Do you want to learn the technique? I can lend you the technique if you want."

"Really? You won't mind?" Yuan asked her.

"I don't mind. I bought it with my own money, and I have already learned it."

Xia Jingyi then took out the technique from her spatial ring before handing it to Yuan casually.

Yuan was speechless. He didn't think she'd be willing to give him an Earth-grade technique so easily and completely for free.

"You're too generous, Jingyi." Yu Rou chuckled.

"I owe you," Yuan said to her.

He then opened the book and started reading it.

"Eh? You're going to study it now? It took me almost two weeks to learn it..." Xia Jingyi said to him.

<You have learned Silent Pulse of Internal Destruction>

"It's okay. I have already learned the technique." Yuan said as she closed the book literally half a minute later.

"W-What?" Xia Jingyi stared at him with a baffled look on her face.

"Hahaha... You should look at your own face right now, Jingyi. Did you forget? My brother is a once-in-a-thousand-years genius who has mastered multiple instruments at a young age." Yu Rou said to her.

"Oh, right... I forgot about that... Sorry."

"Why are you apologizing? Here's the technique. Thanks again." Yuan returned the technique to her after holding it for less than a minute.

"Let's harvest their horns before we continue." Yu Rou then said.

After spending a couple of minutes removing the black horns, Xiao Hua used her Divine Sense to look for more Black Horn Bulls.

"A mile that way," she pointed to the south a moment later.

"Alright, let's go. I want to test out my new technique already." Yuan said, eagerly heading in that direction.

While they walked, Xia Jingyi asked Yu Rou in a low voice, "How does she do that? Locating the Black Horn Bulls from so far away. And who is she? I have been wondering for a while now."

"Xiao Hua? Hmm... How should I explain this..." Yu Rou pondered for a moment before continuing, "Well, she's an NPC— a really powerful one at that, and she's currently traveling with my brother for some reason."

"What? She's an NPC? I couldn't tell at all..." Xia Jingyi said.

"That happens a lot in this game— too often, in fact."

Sometime later, they found more Black Horn Bulls traveling slowly in a group.

"Great. Now let me test out this new technique..." Yuan said.

"Do you want to use my zither as well?" Xia Jingyi asked him.

"It's fine, I have my own zither. Thank you for the offer, though."

He then retrieved the Soul Ensnaring Zither.

"Wow... What a beautiful zither..." Xia Jingyi muttered in awe when she saw his zither, thinking to herself that it must be a high-grade treasure.

Chapter 464 - Please Have Mercy!

After retrieving the Soul Ensnaring Zither, Yuan took a seat on the soft ground and placed the zither on his l.a.p.

He then closed his eyes and took a deep breath.

A moment of pure silence later, he opened his eyes, and his fingers flicked the strings extremely quickly.

Whoosh!

A massive ripple appeared from the zither and swept the place in an instant.

The next second, the Black Horn Bulls didn't even have the time to react before their bodies exploded into a bloody mess.

When Xia Jingyi used the technique, the Black Horn Bulls didn't explode violently, so when she saw the results, she began gagging from shock, nearly puking.

"Whoa... brother... I think you went a little overboard..." Even Yu Rou had to take a step back with a disgusted look on her face after seeing the magical beasts' guts and internal organs flying all over the place. Even though they were magical beasts, Yu Rou felt sorry for them.

Luckily for them, they were standing far enough, or the blood and organs would've definitely hit them.

Yuan's jaw dropped wide open when he saw the results.

"I-I also didn't think it would be so powerful!" He exclaimed a moment later.

"Brother Tian... Did you forget your cultivation base? Even a Mortal-rank cultivation technique will display extraordinary strength if it's used by you." Xiao Hua said to him.

"Even if you say that, this is my first time using a zither technique, so I didn't know how to control my strength." Yuan sighed.

"There's no way we can harvest their horns when they're in this state..." Meixiu said a moment later.

"I'm sorry..." Yuan apologized to them.

"Brother, you're banned from using that technique if we're with you! It's simply too gruesome!" Yu Rou said to him afterward.

"I understand." Yuan nodded.

He then turned to look at Xia Jingyi and asked her, "Are you okay?"

She wiped the tears from her eyes and nodded, "Yes... I was just... shocked..."

"I'm sorry..." He apologized again.

Shortly after, they went to look for more Black Horn Bulls.

"Meixiu, do you want to try fighting them?" Yu Rou suddenly asked her.

"Eh? I don't know any techniques besides my cultivation technique..." she said.

"What? You still don't have any techniques?" Yu Rou looked at her with wide eyes.

She then looked at Yuan, who merely shook his head and said, "Looks like we'll be returning to the Myriad of Techniques sooner than I'd anticipated..."

Since Meixiu didn't have any martial techniques, Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi took care of the magical beasts without making a huge mess.

After that batch, they continued to spend a couple more hours hunting Black Horn Bulls until they essentially hunted almost all of them in the area.

"How many horns did we collect?" Yu Rou asked Yuan at the end.

"About 400 give or take," he said.

"So 4,000 gold coins, huh? That's extremely good for a single quest, and it didn't even take us that long." Yu Rou said.

"And it is mostly thanks to Xiao Hua for locating the magical beasts for us or this would've taken much longer, so thank you, Xiao Hua!"

Xiao Hua nodded silently.

"Are we going to go back now?" Yuan asked them.

"Yes. Once we hand in our quest, we can go shopping for some cultivation techniques. Though I doubt 4,000 gold coins will be enough to buy even half a technique..." Yu Rou said.

"Money, huh? Xiao Hua, do you still have the spirit stones I gave you? Feng Feng said that you didn't spend it."

Xiao Hua nodded and retrieved the storage pouch containing the spirit stones and handed it to him, "Xiao Hua didn't use it, and if Brother Tian needs more money, Xiao Hua still has the money from the auction."

Xiao Hua reminded him that she still has money from selling her Heaven-grade treasure, something that even she forgot about for a moment.

"Okay. We'll use it if we really need it." Yuan nodded, no longer feeling as reluctant to use that money anymore for some reason.

Sometime later, they returned to the carriage, where the driver was taking a nap.

"Hmm? Are you ready to return to the city already, esteemed guests?" The driver woke up when he noticed their presence.

"Yes."

Once everyone was inside the carriage, the driver began driving the carriage back to the city.

"Meixiu, what martial technique do you want? In fact, what kind of weapons do you want to use?" Yuan asked her.

"I don't know..."

"Do you have any experience with weapons? I know you have combat experience working as a servant for the Yu Family since you're expected to be a bodyguard as well. What did your mother teach you?" Yu Rou asked her.

"Well... Everything..." Meixiu said.

"When we're trained, we're not just trained as servants. We also have bodyguard training as well as other things, and as the future personal servant of Yua— Yu Tian, I had to train more than the others, so I am proficient with a lot of weapons, especially guns." Meixiu said.

"Wow... I didn't know that." Yuan began seeing Meixiu in a new light now.

Yu Rou chuckled and said, "Brother, Meixiu is probably strong enough to beat you in a fight without any cultivation techniques or cultivation."

"Really? She's that powerful?" Yuan's eyes widened.

Yu Rou nodded, "I have seen her beat up people twice her size by accident once. It really widened my eyes."

Meixiu blushed slightly after hearing Yu Rou's words.

"Anyways, guns, huh? Are there any weapons in the cultivation world that resemble guns?" Yu Rou wondered.

"What's a gun?" Xiao Hua asked.

"Well... How should I explain this? It's a weapon that comes in many different sizes and shapes, but they all do the same thing— shooting bullets." Yu Rou said.

However, Xiao Hua didn't understand a word she'd just said.

Meixiu then said, "Imagine a weapon that can shoot a small rock so quickly that it can pierce one's body. Kind of like a bow and an arrow."

Xiao Hua pondered for a moment and said, "Like a slingshot?"

"Yes, something like that."

Xiao Hua then shook her head and said, "Xiao Hua has never seen anyone using slingshots as a weapon of choice, but there are many people who use bows and arrows."

"Bows... I have never used a bow before." Meixiu said.

"What about just using your fists, Meixiu? Besides guns, you should also have plenty of hand-to-hand combat," said Yu Rou.

Meixiu nodded.

"Hand techniques, huh? I actually have one on me right now." Yuan suddenly said.

And he asked her, "Do you want to try learning it?"

"Okay."

Yuan then retrieved the Ancient-rank technique he'd obtained from the Dragon Temple and handed it to Meixiu in a casual manner. While he also wanted to learn the technique, he never really got the chance to do so, as he

has been busy with cultivation in the real world shortly after leaving the Dragon Temple.

"Thank you."

After accepting the technique, she opened it.

Meixiu's eyes widened when she saw the rank of the technique, but she didn't say anything, and she proceeded to study the technique until they returned to Seashell City a few hours later.

"How was it? Were you able to understand it?" Yuan asked her.

Meixiu shook her head and said, "I think the technique is too complex for me right now."

"I see... Don't worry, I'm sure we'll find something suitable for you at the Myriad of Techniques." Yuan said to her after storing the technique back into his spatial ring.

"Thank you for your business." The driver said to them after dropping them off inside the city.

Yu Rou and the others began making their way back to the store to turn in their harvest.

"Welcome, young lady. Hmm? You're back already? Did you forget something?" The manager there asked Yu Rou when she returned much faster than he'd anticipated.

"No, I am here to hand in the horns we have hunted." Yu Rou said.

The manager raised his eyebrows upon hearing this. He can only imagine how little horns they have collected after leaving for such a short time, but he didn't say that to them.

"Okay. Let me see how many you've collected. 10 gold coins each," he said a moment later.

Yu Rou then looked at Yuan and said, "Let him see them, brother."

Yuan nodded and went to look for an empty and spacious spot to dump the black horns.

Once he found the spot, he went there and began dumping out the black horns from his spatial ring.

The manager's jaw dropped when he saw the black horns piling up into a small mountain inside his shop. In fact, he has never seen so many black horns gathered in the same place at once before.

And the manager began worrying about whether he would be able to afford to pay them for so many black horns.

Yu Rou chuckled when she saw the manager's reaction, as this reminded her of her first quest with Yuan when they had to gather Spirit Grass, and Xiao Hua collected so much that the manager of that store began sweating.

"Okay, that should be the last one. Please count them." Yuan said to the manager after dumping out all of the black horns.

The manager showed a crying smile before kneeling on the floor and crying out loud, "Please have mercy!"

The manager's response immediately dumbfounded Yuan and the others, as they didn't know why he was crying or pleading for mercy.

Chapter 465 - Returning to the Myriad of Techniques

"W-Why are you on the floor?" Yuan asked the manager in a dumbfounded voice.

"Please, Young Master, have mercy! Even if you take out so many black horns, my store cannot afford all of them!" The manager said in a crying voice.

"Ehh..." Yuan was speechless.

This is the reason why he kowtowed to them? Can't he simply tell them that they didn't have enough money?

"That's fine. How much can you buy?"

The manager lifted his head and asked in a dumbfounded voice, "Y-You're willing to forgive me?"

"Yes?" Yuan said.

The manager then stood up and said, "A-About 100 horns is the most I can afford."

"That's fine."

"Thank you, Young Master! Please give me a minute to prepare the money!"

About ten minutes later, the manager returned with a thousand gold coins in his hands.

"Here you go, Young Master."

After accepting the money, Yuan handed it to Yu Rou.

"Shall we leave now?"

Yu Rou nodded.

"W-Wait a moment... Young Master, what about the rest of your black horns?" The manager asked him.

"Hm? Oh, you can keep them." Yuan said in a casual manner.

"Excuse me?" The manager looked at him with wide eyes filled with disbelief.

"Even if you cannot buy them, we have no use for them, so we'll give them to you for free," Yuan said to the manager.

"R-Really?"

"Yes. You don't mind it either, right, Yu Rou?" Yuan asked her.

"I don't really care. We did it mostly for the experience, anyway," she nodded.

Although 3,000 gold coins may be worth a lot to the average player, in front of Yu Rou, who was exposed to wealth countless times more than that by Yuan, it was as little as a drop of water in an ocean.

"Thank you very much, esteemed guests!" The manager bowed to them and refused to lift his head until they left.

"Are we going to the Myriad of Techniques now?" Yu Rou asked after they left.

"It's getting dark outside so let's wait until tomorrow," Yuan said as he looked at the darkening sky.

"Alright. See you guys later." Yu Rou said to them.

"Goodnight." Xia Jingyi said.

After logging off, Meixiu began cooking dinner.

Meanwhile, Yuan tried his best to breakthrough to Spirit Master.

'I should've asked Xiao Hua when I had the chance... I guess I will do it tomorrow.' Yuan sighed inwardly.

After failing to breakthrough, Yuan stopped trying until after dinner.

The following morning, after breakfast, Yuan and Meixiu met up with Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi.

"Good morning, brother." Yu Rou waved at them.

"Good morning." Xia Jingyi said.

"Morning. Are you guys ready to head to the Myriad of Techniques?" Yuan asked them.

"Yes!"

"Is there one in this city?" Yuan then asked.

"There is. I looked it up yesterday. Follow me." Yu Rou said to them.

Yuan and the others followed Yu Rou, and after walking for about twenty minutes, they arrived at this ordinary-looking store.

"It feels like yesterday..." Yuan mumbled in a low voice.

They entered the store a moment later, and a beautiful woman greeted them with a bright smile on her face.

However, this beautiful woman wasn't Zhu Yuying like Yuan had expected; it was an entirely different person.

'She did say that she'll be replaced soon...' Yuan thought to himself.

"Welcome to the Myriad of Techniques. If this is your first time at our store, please put your hand on this crystal ball."

Xia Jingyi stepped forward and placed her hand on the crystal ball, which glowed a golden color.

"A heavenly destiny? Congratulations, young lady. You can access the first and second floor of the store. As for everyone else, you may go to whichever floor you're authorized, and don't try to cheat, because we have records of your results." The woman said to them.

Once they passed the entrance, Yuan said to them, "Meixiu, Yu Rou, Jingyi, you three can go look for a technique. I will be in the waiting room."

"You're not coming with us?" Yu Rou asked him.

"I want to take this time to learn a technique that I've recently acquired, and I have something to talk to Xiao Hua about."

"Okay. Then we'll be back!"

After Yu Rou and the others left, Xiao Hua turned to look at Yuan and asked him, "Brother Yuan wants to speak with Xiao Hua?"

Yuan nodded and said, "To be completely honest, I think I am at a bottleneck. Do you remember that one time when you shared your experience breaking through to Spirit Warrior with me? Can you also do the same for Spirit Master?"

"Brother Yuan is at a bottleneck? How is that possible?" Xiao Hua raised her eyebrows.

"Well... It's a little bit complicated..." He sighed.

"It's okay. If Brother Yuan needs help, Xiao Hua will do everything in her power to assist."

"Thank you."

Once they were in the waiting room that was a spacious area with many chairs spread out, Yuan took a seat on the floor and Xiao Hua stood in front of him.

She then raised her hand and poked him in the forehead with a soft glow on the tip of her fingers.

Yuan closed his eyes the next moment, and he began experiencing what Xiao Hua had experienced when she tried to breakthrough to Spirit Master.

Meanwhile, on the first floor of the store, Yu Rou and the other two ladies wandered around the store.

"Do you have any techniques in mind?" Yu Rou asked Meixiu.

"No idea."

"Hmmm... I also don't have any idea. Let's just look around, I guess."

As for Yuan, he'd experience breaking through to Spirit Master hundreds... thousands of times in these hours.

Chapter 466 - Ancient Seal

After spending a few hours experiencing Xiao Hua's experience, Yuan finally opened his eyes and looked around.

"They're not back yet?"

"They came back about an hour ago to tell us that they'll need a few more hours on the second floor, but Brother Yuan was absorbed in his own thing." Xiao Hua said to him.

"Oh, I see. That's fine. I still have a technique to learn, anyway."

"And thanks for showing me your experience, Xiao Hua. I think I understand why I cannot breakthrough."

"Why?" Xiao Hua asked.

"It's most likely due to the lack of spiritual energy in that place," he said.

Xiao Hua nodded and said, "Spiritual energy is incredibly important when one is trying to breakthrough because they'll need a massive amount of spiritual energy, hence why people usually choose a place with the most spiritual energy before they attempt to breakthrough."

"I see... This is going to be pretty tricky..." Yuan sighed.

As a cripple who cannot move without the assistance of a wheelchair and Meixiu, it would be difficult for him to find a location with better spiritual energy than his room, and because of their situation, it wouldn't be smart to wander outside.

'I guess I will have to put my breakthrough on hold and practice my Divine Sense for now.' Yuan thought to himself.

"If Brother Yuan cannot find a place with good spiritual energy, he can look for treasures that contain a large amount of spiritual energy instead," Xiao Hua suddenly said.

"A treasure? That's even more tricky..." Yuan said, as he wasn't sure if there were any treasures in the real world that contain spiritual energy.

'If only we can somehow transfer the treasures in this world back to the real world...' Yuan sighed inwardly.

Unfortunately, unlike transferring knowledge from Cultivation Online to the real world, it was simply impossible to transfer physical objects like treasures to the real world no matter how he thought about it.

"Thanks for the advice, Xiao Hua," Yuan said to her before taking out the Ancient-rank martial technique he'd obtained from the Dragon Temple and reading through it.

There was a handsome young man with long blonde hair practicing on a mountain peak, and every time he punched his fists out, it would create the image of a dragon that would fly into the distance before creating a hole in whatever it touched.

"What a powerful technique..." Yuan mumbled in a low voice as he continued to watch this talented youth practice the technique 'Relentless Dragon Overwhelms the Nine Heavens'.

Of course, what Yuan was experiencing right now didn't occur to Meixiu when she tried to learn the technique in the carriage. Perhaps it had something to do with their compatibility, but Yuan comprehended the technique at a frightening rate.

While Yuan tried to comprehend the technique, Xiao Hua sat beside him like some kind of guardian, making sure that nobody disturbs him.

However, no matter how powerful Xiao Hua may be, she didn't have the capabilities to protect Yuan from everything, and one of these things being sound.

"AAAAAH!"

A loud voice suddenly resounded in the waiting room, snapping Yuan back to reality.

"It's you again! You're definitely stalking me!"

Yuan frowned when he heard this voice, and he turned to look at the door, where a blonde-haired beauty was standing with a couple of techniques in her grasp.

"What are you doing here? I have been here since this morning." Yuan said to her.

"And I have been here since last night!" she quickly responded.

"Don't you get tired of this? Just go on and continue your trial for the Four Ancient Families," Yuan sighed out loud.

"S-So you knew my identity this entire time?! And you still claim that you're not stalking me? I don't buy it!" The girl said to him with a look of disbelief on her face.

"No... Somebody recognized your uniform and told me... You know what... Forget it... There's no point talking to you." Yuan sighed out loud.

The fierce girl gritted her teeth and said, "Y-You're freaking lucky that we're inside the Myriad of Techniques right now, or I would've already smashed your face in!"

Yuan shrugged and responded in a calm voice, "Did you not learn from last time? Go ahead and punch me if you want to experience that pain again."

The girl suddenly felt a dull pain on her feet when Yuan reminded her about the last incident.

"Hmph! Forget it! You can follow me all you like, but if you dare to try and do anything funny, I will smash your face in!" The fierce girl then took a seat on the other side of the room and proceeded to ignore him.

However, to Yuan's surprise, Xiao Hua stood up and approached the fierce girl.

The girl turned to look at Xiao Hua with a frown on her face.

"What do you want?"

Xiao Hua stared at her for a good moment before speaking, "You're from the four Ancient Families, right? How much power do you hold within the family?"

"Huh? Why do you care?"

Xiao Hua then said, "Do you have the Ancient Seal?"

The girl's eyes widened with surprise, and she quickly stood up and backed away from Xiao Hua.

"Who are you? Why do you know about the Ancient Seal?"

"..."

"I asked you a question! Why do you know about the Ancient Seal?!"

The fierce girl then raised her hand before throwing it at Xiao Hua's face.

"Xiao Hua!" Yuan stood up, but before he could even do anything, Xiao Hua waved her sleeves and calmly caught the attack perfectly.

"Y-You..." The girl's eyes widened with shock after feeling an unfathomable strength coming from Xiao Hua.

Chapter 467 - Primordial Realm

"Let me go!" The fierce lady shouted when Xiao Hua didn't release her fist.

"If anything happens to me, my family will, without a doubt, avenge me!"

After a moment of silence, Xiao Hua released her grasp on the lady, letting her free.

"Now tell me how you know about the Ancient Seal!" The lady repeated.

"That is something only the top ranks in the family should know about!"

"If you do not have the Ancient Seal, then Xiao Hua is no longer interested in speaking with you." Xiao Hua said to her before turning around and walking back to Yuan in a nonchalant manner.

"Y-You little brat!" The fierce girl gritted her teeth, yet she didn't dare to approach Xiao Hua.

"If you don't tell me how you know about the Ancient Seal, I will tell my family about you! You can either answer me or answer my family! And if you choose the latter, just know that they won't be as patient as I am now!"

Xiao Hua turned to look at her and said, "The Ancient Seal may be a secret in the Lower Heavens, but in the upper heavens, everybody knows about it."

"What?" The girl's eyes widened with shock, as this was new information for her.

"A-Are you trying to tell me that you're from the upper heavens? What are you doing here? And why do you need the Ancient Seal?" she asked Xiao

Hua.

Xiao Hua didn't say anything and turned back around, ignoring her.

"I-If you tell me, I will tell you where the Ancient Seal is!" The girl suddenly said.

Xiao Hua immediately turned around upon hearing this, but when she saw the girl's face, Xiao Hua turned back around and said, "You're lying."

"W-What! I am not lying! I will really tell you!"

However, Xiao Hua ignored her.

"Fine! If you want to play this game, I will play with you!"

"Is everything okay, Xiao Hua? Wouldn't it be problematic if the Four Ancient Families came after us?" Yuan asked her afterward.

Xiao Hua nodded and said, "She won't tell her family about this, and even if they do come after us, Xiao Hua can deal with them."

"You sound confident that she won't tell her family. Why is that?" Yuan asked.

"Because she cannot contact her family unless she completes her trial no matter the situation."

"I see... What about the Ancient Seal? What is that?"

"The Ancient Seal is a treasure that each of the Four Ancient Families owns, and if one gathers all four, they will get to enter the Primordial Realm."

"Primordial Realm? What kind of place is that?" Yuan asked, his interest piqued.

"..."

Xiao Hua looked at Yuan in silence for a good moment before mumbling in a low voice, "The Primordial Realm is Xiao Hua's home..."

"What?" Yuan's eyes widened with surprise.

"Home as in the place you were born?" Yuan asked her.

Xiao Hua nodded.

"The Primordial Realm is a special place that isn't part of the Nine Heavens, and Xiao Hua was born there. However, due to reasons, Xiao Hua had to leave the Primordial Realm."

After pondering for a moment, Yuan decided to ask her a question that he has been curious about for a long time now.

"Does it have anything to do with being an 'exile'?"

"Eh?"

Xiao Hua's eyes widened with shock upon hearing his question.

"W-When did Brother Yuan learn about exiles...?" Xiao Hua asked him in a shaky voice, clearly feeling nervous.

"I have known about it for over a month now, but to tell you the truth, I have no idea what an exile is, and I was hoping to get some clarification from you," Yuan said.

Seeing Xiao Hua's nervousness, Yuan continued in a gentle voice, "Xiao Hua, no matter who you are or what background you have, I will always be on your side. I am asking because I am worried that you might need help, but I won't be able to help you if I don't know anything."

After a moment of silence, Xiao Hua nodded and said, "An exile is someone who has been banished from the Nine Heavens by the Celestial Emperor, and the Primordial Realm is a place where exiles gather. Xiao Hua's family did something bad in the past, so everyone in the family was exiled. Of course, this included the future generations of the family."

"What? So someone in your family did something bad and everyone in the family got punished—including the innocent?" Yuan was speechless, finding the judgment to be cruel and unfair, especially towards the innocent children and those who will join the family in the future.

Xiao Hua nodded and continued, "Once exiled, they cannot enter the Nine Heavens again, or they will be hunted by everyone in the Nine Heavens. And once someone is branded as an exile, they cannot remove that title no matter how much time passes or what they do. However, there is one exception—the Supreme Heaven's Legacy."

"If an exile can fulfill the Legacy, that person and their family will be allowed to return to the Nine Heavens and will no longer be regarded as exiles."

"However, only one person per family can hold the Legacy, and Xiao Hua was chosen to fulfill this Legacy."

"Unbelievable... To think your family would give someone so young so much responsibility, forcing you to bear such a heavy burden..." Yuan sighed.

"It's okay. Xiao Hua wanted to do it as well."

"As for your legacy... We just need to reach the Supreme Heaven, right?" Yuan then asked.

Xiao Hua nodded, and she said, "Yes, but reaching the Supreme Heaven is just the beginning of the legacy. Xiao Hua doesn't know anything else beyond that."

"It's okay. We'll find out when we get there." Yuan said.

"Brother Yuan, there's still one more thing you should know about exiles..." she suddenly said.

Yuan looked at her with a smile and said, "It's okay. You can tell me."

Chapter 468 - Hunted by the Nine Heavens

"As an exile, despite holding the Supreme Heaven's Legacy, Xiao Hua will be constantly hunted by other cultivators, so she might bring trouble to Brother Yuan." Xiao Hua said to him.

"What? Why do you have to be hunted when you're a legacy holder?" Yuan asked her with wide eyes.

"Because that's how the Celestial Emperor made it. He wanted to make it as difficult as possible for exiles to escape their fate. If it was so easy to complete the legacy, people would've escaped the Primordial Realm long ago. However, after millions of years, nobody has managed to achieve true freedom." Xiao Hua said.

"Not only are we hunted by everyone in the Nine Heavens, but we also have our strength limited so that we wouldn't be able to ascend too quickly."

"That's... That's just not fair... It's like they're treating exiles as animals." Yuan was speechless.

"Fortunately, Xiao Hua won't have to worry about being hunted until after the third heaven, where cultivators have the ability to discern those who are exiles."

'Is this why Miss Xu warned me to leave Xiao Hua's side as soon as possible? Because Xiao Hua will be constantly hunted by others, and if I am with her, I might also get hunted...' Yuan finally realized why Xu Jiaqi said what she said at that time.

It turned out that she was only concerned about him.

However, even if the entire world goes after Xiao Hua, Yuan has already decided that he wouldn't abandon her no matter what.

"Don't worry, Xiao Hua. Even if the entire world is against you, I will be on your side. In the first place, you didn't do anything wrong. If I ever get a chance to speak with the Celestial Emperor, I am going to give him a piece of my mind and seek justice for you."

"Thank you, Brother Yuan." Xiao Hua said, feeling relieved that Yuan didn't decide to abandon her because of her status.

"Xiao Hua, do you wish to visit your home? Is that why you asked that girl for the Ancient Seal?" Yuan asked her a moment later.

Xiao Hua nodded and said, "One cannot leave the Primordial Realm without the Supreme Heaven's Legacy, but once they leave, they cannot return to the Primordial Realm without the Ancient Seal."

"With the Ancient Seals, one can enter the Primordial Realm as they wish."

"I see... Do you think the Four Ancient Families will lend us their Ancient Seals?"

"Probably not... But it doesn't matter what the Four Ancient Families think. As long as the person holding the Ancient Seal is willing, they can hand over the Ancient Seal." Xiao Hua said.

"Oh? Who is currently holding the Ancient Seals? We won't know unless we try." Yuan said, sounding a little enthusiastic.

Xiao Hua shook her head and said, "Xiao Hua only knows that each family has one person holding the Ancient Seal, but that person's identity is very secretive, and only important figures in the families would hold such information."

"Furthermore, the person holding the Ancient Seal can be anywhere in the Nine Heavens. For example, there could be a seal holder in the third heaven

while the other seal holders are in the other heavens. After all, the Four Ancient Families exist all over the Nine Heavens."

"What? So you're telling me that there could be a seal holder in the Supreme Heaven? That makes things even more complicated..." Yuan sighed.

"Yes, but the four Ancient Seal holders will gather in the same location once every 10 years to make sure that everybody still has their seal. If we can find out the location and time of their next meeting, perhaps we might be able to meet all of them at once." Xiao Hua said.

"But just meeting them won't do any good. We need to convince them to lend us their Ancient Seals too, and that will probably be the hardest part."

"Brother Yuan, we should forget about this for now. There's no point looking for the Ancient Seals now. Even if we somehow acquire it now, we won't be able to go there," she said.

"Eh? Why not?" Yuan asked.

"Because Brother Yuan is too weak. If we go there now, you will most definitely die."

"What? The Primordial Realm is that dangerous? I thought it was your home?" Yuan's eyes widened with surprise.

"Yes, that is where Xiao Hua's family is located, but there are other exiles living there as well, not to mention the chaotic energy in that world. It's called the Primordial Realm mainly because of the chaotic energy that's very common in the Primordial Era, and if one doesn't have sufficient cultivation, they will be crushed to death just by being around that chaotic energy."

"Wow... Doesn't this mean everybody living inside the Primordial Realm are incredibly powerful cultivators?" Yuan asked.

Xiao Hua nodded and said, "They are so powerful that when babies are born, they already have the cultivation base of a Spirit Lord."

"What! Born as a Spirit Lord?! People can be born as cultivators?!" Yuan was shocked when he heard this, as this is his first time hearing such information.

"Yes. In the upper heavens, many people are born already with a cultivation base because their parents help them by nurturing them with spiritual energy even before they are born."

"Heavens... Now I really want to go to the Primordial Realm..." Yuan mumbled to himself.

Sometime later, Yuan returned to studying the Ancient-rank technique until Yu Rou and the others returned.

"Sorry, it took so long, brother. There were just so many techniques to look at and we didn't know what we wanted." Yu Rou apologized to him afterward.

"I don't mind," Yuan said.

"Since you're back, does this mean you're finally finished? What kind of cultivation techniques did you guys pick?" Yuan asked them, and he could see each of them holding onto scrolls.

"Well, we picked a lot, but we're not sure if we want them just yet since we still need to see if we can afford them." Yu Rou said.

Chapter 469 - Free

"Don't worry about the price. I will pay for them even if you can afford it." Yuan said to Yu Rou after hearing her words.

"Really?" Yu Rou's eyes flickered with excitement.

Although it felt weird at first, she eventually got used to being spoiled by Yuan. Now, she even enjoys being spoiled.

"Meixiu, Miss Xia, I will also pay for your techniques."

"Eh? You don't have to pay for my stuff as well..." Xia Jingyi said in a surprised voice, and she continued, "Also, you can just call me Jingyi. It feels weird being called 'Miss' by someone older than me."

"It's okay. Just let me pay for it. It'll also feel weird for me if I pay for everyone else but you." Yuan insisted on paying for her cultivation techniques.

"O-Okay... Thank you, Senior Yu."

"Senior Yu? Just call me Yu Tian." Yuan chuckled.

"Anyways, let's go check out the techniques."

A few minutes later, they arrived at the reception desk.

"Hello, we'd like to check the prices for these techniques." Yu Rou said to the young man working behind the desk.

"Hmm?"

"Oh, I remember you. You're that girl who bought the Wind Blade technique a while ago." The young man said, as he was there during Yuan and Yu Rou's first visit to the store.

He then turned to look at Yuan, "It's good to see you again, Senior."

"Hello. You're still working at the desk? You don't have to rotate with another person like Zhu Yuying?" Yuan asked him.

"Haha... I am a permanent worker here, so no, I don't have any replacements," he said.

"I see... Anyways, how much for these techniques?"

"Let me see what you got."

Yu Rou and the others placed the techniques in their grasp on the table, and the young man immediately began looking through the scrolls.

"Your total will come out to 0 gold coins." The young man said with a smile on his face.

"Excuse me?" Yu Rou raised her eyebrows in a puzzled manner, clearly doubting what she'd just heard.

"Did you just say 0 gold coins? Isn't that basically free?" Yuan asked with a surprised look on his face.

"Yes, it's free." The young man nodded.

"Why is it free?" Xia Jingyi asked him.

The young man looked at Yuan and said, "As long as you're part of the faction, everything in the Myriad of Techniques is free as long as the technique is below Heaven-rank."

"Faction? What is he talking about, brother?" Yu Rou turned to ask him.

"Ehh... I will explain later." Yuan said.

Then he turned to look at the young man and asked, "Are there any limitations? Like I cannot share or sell the techniques. After all, getting all of the techniques I want for free sounds a little bit... too good to be true..."

"The only limitation is that you are limited to 10 free techniques a year. If you want to sell or share the technique, you are free to do so." The young man said.

Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi turned to look at each other with dumbfounded expressions on their faces. They were shocked speechless by Yuan's privilege. What exactly is a faction, and how do they join it?

'My parents had to shell out a few billion dollars to acquire a Heaven-rank cultivation technique, but Brother Tian only needed to join a faction to obtain 10 free techniques every year as long as it's below Heaven-rank?' Yu Rou thought to herself.

"If you think this is too good to be true, just wait until you achieve a higher faction rank, since the higher your rank, the better techniques you get to take for free." The young man continued.

"A-Are you also part of the faction?" Yuan couldn't help but ask him.

"Hahaha... of course, not. It's too unrealistic for me—to the point where I cannot even dream about being part of Master Bai's faction."

"Eh? Then how did you know that I am part of the faction?" Yuan then asked.

The young man then retrieved a talisman from under the desk and said, "When this talisman glows gold, it means there's someone from the faction in front of me. That's how I knew."

"Wow, that's pretty neat. Do you think I can get one as well?"

"I'm sorry, Senior, but this isn't something that can be given to everyone even if they're from the faction. I only have one because I am working at

the Myriad of Techniques. If you want one, you'll have to acquire the rank of Captain." The young man explained to him.

"I see... Thanks for letting me know." Yuan said.

He then turned to look at Yu Rou and the others.

"Since I can acquire any technique below Heaven-rank for free and I still have ten slots this year, do you want to go back and look around some more? I wouldn't be surprised if there were some techniques that caught your interest but you decided to ignore them because you were worried about the price."

"R-Really? You're going to use your precious 10 slots for us?" Yu Rou looked at him with wide eyes.

"Yes. I don't mind." Yuan nodded.

"Thank you, brother! I love you!" Yu Rou said to him.

"T-Thank you, Yu Tian. I will definitely return this favor one day in the future." Xia Jingyi lowered her head and bowed to him.

"Guess I will hold onto these techniques for now." The young man said with a smile on his face.

Yu Rou and the others left the place shortly after and returned to the second floor to look at the techniques one more time.

"Yingying, what about you? You only know a single technique right now, right? You should look around, too." Yuan said to her afterward.

Lan Yingying then appeared before him and said, "Is it really okay for me to get a technique as well?"

"Of course." He nodded.

Chapter 470 - Contest

Once everyone beside Xiao Hua left, Yuan returned to the waiting room and proceeded to continue studying the Ancient-rank fist technique.

Even though he clearly showed great compatibility with the technique, Yuan was unable to learn this technique as easily as he learned the other techniques.

'As expected of an Ancient-rank technique. I cannot learn it as quickly as I learned the other techniques.' Yuan thought to himself.

'Now that I think about it, the Dragon's Gaze is also an Ancient-rank technique, and it took me a couple of weeks to learn that technique. Although only a week had passed in real-time, I had experienced many weeks while I was studying the technique inside my head, so I should still count it as such.'

If he uses the Dragon's Gaze as an example, he will probably need at least a few weeks to learn the fist technique.

Though, this didn't discourage Yuan. In fact, it only made him study the technique even more seriously.

Time passed extremely quickly while Yuan was absorbed in studying the technique, and before he was aware, the ladies returned to his side with new techniques in their grasp.

"We're back, brother." Yu Rou said to him.

Yuan opened his eyes and looked at them.

Both Meixiu and Xia Jingyi were holding a single scroll while Yu Rou had two scrolls.

Yuan looked around for Lan Yingying.

"Brother? Who are you looking for?" Yu Rou asked him.

"Yingying. She's still looking for a technique," he said.

"Yingying? Who?" Yu Rou raised her eyebrows.

"Uhhh... I forgot to introduce her to you, but her name is Lan Yingying, and she's like Xiao Hua and Feng Feng." Yuan gave her a brief explanation.

"Like Xiao Hua and Feng Feng?" Yu Rou pondered.

'Oh, I completely forgot... Brother Tian had acquired an Ancient-grade servant during the Mystic Realm... I wonder what she looks like...' Yu Rou recalled the announcement that shook the internet for an entire week.

About an hour later, a white-haired beauty entered the waiting room, instantly catching Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi's attention.

"I apologize for making you wait so long, my Lord." Lan Yingying said to him after she returned.

"My lord?" Yu Rou raised her eyebrows.

Lan Yingying bowed to Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi and said, "Hello. My name is Lan Yingying, and I am the Lord's servant."

'Servant? Is she roleplaying?' Xia Jingyi wondered inwardly, as she wasn't aware of Lan Yingying's true identity as a Divine Beast.

"Hello... I am Yu Rou, and I am Yu Tian's younger sister." Yu Rou introduced herself.

"Xia Jingyi, and I am Yu Rou's classmate." Xia Jingyi said.

"By the way, Yingying is an NPC," Yuan said to Xia Jingyi.

"Eh? Oh... Then she probably doesn't know about classmates... Well, we're something like fellow disciples of the same sect." Xia Jingyi explained herself afterward.

After their introduction, Yuan took them back to the young man at the reception diest.

"Six Heaven-rank techniques, huh? What about the ones you found previously? Do you still want them?" The young man asked them.

"No, we'll just take the new techniques." Yu Rou shook her head.

"I understand. I will place them back for you later."

"Sorry for the trouble," Yuan said.

"Don't mention it. I am merely doing my job."

The young man proceeded to log in the techniques they took, and after a couple of minutes, he handed the scrolls back to Yu Rou and the others.

"Alright. You're all set. Senior, you have 4 more free techniques for the rest of the year. It will reset at the beginning of next year."

"I understand. Thank you." Yuan nodded.

"See you next time, Seniors." The young man bowed to them as they left the place.

"Wow, it's already this late? I would like to study the new techniques, but we can do that later." Yu Rou said when she realized that it was already late at night.

"Goodnight."

After saying their goodbyes, they logged off the game.

"What kind of technique did you get, Meixiu?" Yuan asked her during dinner.

"Oh, it's a movement technique," she said.

"Eh? A movement technique? You only got one technique, right? What about a martial technique? Although having a movement technique is great, you cannot win a fight just by dodging." Yuan said.

"I think I will be fine for a while even without any martial techniques. I have plenty of hand-to-hand combat experience, so I should be fine even without a martial technique," she said in a confident voice.

"I mean, you should be fine without any martial techniques for now since you're still only a Spirit Apprentice in the game, but once you reach a higher cultivation, martial techniques are essential since everyone will have one, and you cannot fight martial technique with b.a.r.e hands."

"Yes, I plan on learning a martial technique in the future, but for now, I am satisfied with just a movement technique," she said.

After dinner, Meixiu went to cultivate while Yuan practiced his Divine Sense.

The following morning, before they could even enter Cultivation Online, Yu Rou called Meixiu's phone.

"Morning, Meixiu."

"Good morning, Yu Rou. What's the matter?"

"Apparently there's a small contest in a nearby city. It's mostly for cultivators between the first level and the third level of Spirit Warrior. Do you want to participate in it? The winner even gets an Earth-rank cultivation technique."

"I don't really care. Do you intend on participating in it?" Meixiu said.

"Yes."

"Even though you just got two Heaven-rank techniques?"

"Hehe... You can never have too many techniques! If the Earth-rank technique isn't any good, I can simply sell it to other players for some money, and then I will give that money to Brother Tian so that I could feel less guilty about taking two Heaven-rank techniques for free." Yu Rou said.

"Also, it will be a good experience for us. Although I have fought plenty of magical beasts, I am still inexperienced with fighting other people."

"Okay. I will tell Yuan. Let's continue this talk inside the game." Meixiu said.

"Alright. See you two in a bit." Yu Rou then hung up.

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Chapter 471 - Fiery Lotus

After meeting up with Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi inside Cultivation Online, Yuan asked them, "You want to participate in a contest?"

"Yes, there will be other players there as well." Yu Rou nodded.

"Are you sure? I assume there will be a lot of players there since there is going to be a free Earth-rank technique." Yuan said.

"Well, it won't hurt to take a look at the place. If there are too many people, we can leave." Yu Rou said.

"Alright. How far is this place? Do we need to take a carriage there?"

"No, it's only about a two-hour walk from here."

They proceeded to leave Seashell City shortly after.

A little over two hours later, they arrived at the city.

However, they were immediately baffled by the number of people there.

"Heavens..." Yu Rou mumbled in a dazed voice when she saw the sea of people outside the city waiting to go inside.

If there were this many people outside the city, she can only imagine how many people were inside.

"I have underestimated the value of an Earth-rank technique... probably because of you, brother..." Yu Rou sighed a moment later.

"Do you still want to participate in the contest?" Yuan asked her with a smile on his face.

"Uhhh... I will be shocked if we can enter the city before the contest is over," she sighed again.

"What else do you want to do now?"

"Well... I kind of want to study the technique I got yesterday."

"Should we go to the Cultivators' Haven?"

"Nah. I'm getting bored of the bland room inside the Cultivators' Haven. We can study outside for a change, and it's not like we're cultivating, so a little disturbance should be fine. There's a lake about a mile away. We can go there instead."

"Alright. Let's go." Yuan nodded.

"Wow, this place is beautiful." Yu Rou said.

"This place kind of reminds me of a school trip we had last year." Xia Jingyi said.

"Oh, you mean the one we had towards the end of the year? I remember, but the water there wasn't this clear."

"The atmosphere here is quite refreshing..." Yuan looked at the lake with a look of admiration.

"This is your first time coming to a place like this, right?" Yu Rou said to him.

"Yes... Our parents would never take us to these kinds of places, after all." He said with a bittersweet smile.

"By the way, where's Miss Lan?" Xia Jingyi asked when she realized that she was gone.

"Oh, she's right here," he said while pointing to the snake bracelet around his wrist.

"Huh?" Xia Jingyi raised her eyebrows upon hearing this.

"Come out for a bit, Yingying."

The next moment, the white bracelet around his arms began moving, before transforming into Lan Yingying.

Xia Jingyi's jaw dropped after seeing her transformation.

"Y-You're not human?" Xia Jingyi asked.

"No, I am a Divine Serpent," Lan Yingying said.

"Do you want to see my beast form?"

Xia Jingyi nodded with curiosity.

"I also want to see it!" Yu Rou said.

Lan Yingying then transformed into her serpent form.

"Whoa! You're very big!" Yu Rou was dumbfounded when Lan Yingying transformed into a massive white snake larger than even a bus, almost like a mini train.

"You have very pretty scales..." Xia Jingyi said with a dazzled look on her face.

"Thank you."

"Hmm? Jingyi, do you like snakes? I thought most girls hate snakes." Yu Rou said.

"Yes, I like snakes. I find them very cute. In fact, I have a pet snake at home." Xia Jingyi nodded.

"Really? I should visit your home one day."

"You can come whenever." Xia Jingyi said.

Sometime later, Lan Yingying returned to her human form.

"I'm going to study the technique now." Yu Rou said to them before taking a seat by the lake and retrieving one of the two Heaven-rank techniques she'd recently acquired.

Xia Jingyi followed her and also started studying her new technique.

"What about you, Yingying? What kind of technique did you take?" Yuan asked her afterward.

"Oh, it's a flame technique. I was hoping it'd synergize with my Sacred Fire," she said.

Lan Yingying then took a seat somewhere in the shades under a tree and began studying the technique.

"I'm also going to study my technique," Meixiu said before going to where Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi were studying.

"Since everyone is studying, I might as well study too, but I kind of want to enjoy the scenery for a bit." Yuan proceeded to lay beside the lake and looked at the sparkling water for a whole hour before he started studying his own technique.

After studying for a few hours, Lan Yingying was the first to learn her new technique.

She then walked to the lake and started practicing her new technique.

Lan Yingying took a deep breath, then she proceeded to summon her Sacred Fire on her palms.

A white ball of fire appeared, and Lan Yingying controlled the Sacred Fire, transforming the ball of fire into the shape of a lotus.

Once she was satisfied with the shape and its consistency, Lan Yingying tossed the lotus into the lake.

Whoosh!

This attracted the attention of everyone there.

"Wow, what beautiful white flames..." Xia Jingyi mumbled in a low voice, seemingly mesmerized by it.

"Look at the flames! It's not going out even though it's touching the water! I have never seen anything like this before!" Yu Rou exclaimed when she noticed the fire wasn't going out as it laid on top of the water, making the lake look as though it was actually on fire.

However, Lan Yingying wasn't satisfied with the results, so she continued to create these flaming lotuses until she ran out of spiritual energy.

By the end of the day, Lan Yingying was capable of creating two lotuses at a time.

"What kind of technique did you learn?" Yu Rou couldn't help but ask her towards the end of the day.

"It's a technique called Fiery Lotus. It significantly enhances the power of flames, but it consumes a lot of spiritual energy," she said.

"Really? It didn't look like it consumes a lot of spiritual energy because you've been shooting them all day." Yu Rou said.

"That's because I made sure to limit the strength of the technique and focused on mastering the control first, and if I used the technique at its full strength, it'd disturb you guys."

"Can you use its full strength now? I am curious."

Lan Yingying nodded.

She then created another lotus using her Sacred Fire, but it was much larger than all of her previous lotuses today.

In fact, compared to the palm-sized lotuses she has been practicing with throughout the day, this one was as large as a large watermelon.

Once she'd poured enough spiritual energy into the lotus, Lan Yingying tossed it towards the lake.

The next moment, the lotus exploded into a fiery hell that consumed the entire lake, illuminating the somewhat dark place.

"Wow! So pretty!" Yu Rou said as she watched the lake burn with white flames that danced on the surface of the water.

Sometime later, Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi logged off after saying their goodbyes.

Yuan and Meixiu also logged off shortly after.

The following morning, Yuan and the others continued to study their techniques by the lake, and they would continue to do this for almost an entire week.

The second person to finish learning her new technique was Meixiu.

On the third day, she started trying out the movement technique, dancing around the place with stiff movements at first, eventually getting better.

"Xiao Hua, can I borrow some of your time? I don't want to bother him since he's studying." Meixiu approached Xiao Hua on the fourth day.

Xiao Hua nodded and followed Meixiu to a spacious area by the lake.

"I would like to test out my movement technique. Can you try hitting me with something?" Meixiu asked Xiao Hua a moment later.

Xiao Hua nodded and retrieved a sword from her storage ring.

Meixiu immediately became nervous.

Seeing Xiao Hua wielding a sword that was as long as her body was a weird experience.

"D-Do you have anything else?"

Xiao Hua shook her head, and then she said, "Don't worry, Xiao Hua won't hit you."

"Okay..." Meixiu decided to trust Xiao Hua, and she took a long and deep breath to calm down.

"Are you ready?" Xiao Hua asked a moment later.

"Yes." Meixiu nodded with a focused look on her face.

Xiao Hua then kicked her feet, closing their distance instantly.

Once she was close enough, Xiao Hua swung the sword at Meixiu.

Whoosh!

The blade narrowly missed Meixiu.

However, Xiao Hua didn't stop and continued to strike at her.

Of course, Xiao Hua adjusted her speed to Meixiu's level. If she moved any quicker, Meixiu wouldn't be able to dodge it at all.

"Ah!"

Meixiu accidentally tripped a few minutes into their training, but there was a sword flying at her neck.

Meixiu subconsciously closed her eyes and prepared for the worst.

However, nothing happened even a moment later.

Meixiu slowly opened her eyes, and to her surprise, the blade stopped a few inches away from her neck.

"Are you okay?" Xiao Hua asked her in a calm voice.

"Yes. Let's continue." Meixiu said after getting up.

Xiao Hua nodded.

They continued to practice shortly after, and Meixiu's movements grew quicker and smoother as time progressed.

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Chapter 472 - Mount Hua Temple

"Haaa... haaa... haaa..."

After half an hour of practicing her movement technique with Xiao Hua, Meixiu collapsed on the ground in an exhausted manner.

It's been a very long time since she's experienced such exhaustion. The only time she can recall feeling this tired was after training with her mother when she was still in servant training.

As for Xiao Hua, she looked completely calm and nonchalant, almost like she has been sitting in the shades this entire time.

"Are you okay?" Xiao Hua asked her a moment after she laid on the floor.

"Yes... thank you... for helping me..." Meixiu said to her.

"If you want more training, just call Xiao Hua," she said to Meixiu before walking back to sit beside Yuan.

After her training, Meixiu took a seat at a nearby tree and enjoyed the shades. The wind would sometimes blow, carrying the refreshing air from the lake and sweeping the area with it.

Once she'd rested for a couple of hours, Meixiu would ask Xiao Hua for help again with her training. Even though it was tiring, Meixiu enjoyed practicing the movement technique that allowed her to move very quickly, and it felt very satisfying whenever she perfectly dodged the sword.

Yu Rou managed to learn one of her two Heaven-rank techniques three days after Meixiu learned her movement technique.

Once she got the notification, Yu Rou retrieved her treasure fan and stood before the lake.

Whoosh!

The wind in the middle of the lake began to twist, and in just a moment, a tornado appeared, swallowing up the water.

Three seconds later, the tornado grew so large that it lowered the water in the lake by a dozen inches.

Yu Rou panicked when she saw how big the tornado was getting, so she quickly stopped it.

Countless drops of water began raining from the sky a moment later despite the clear blue sky, soaking everybody except Xiao Hua and Lan Yingying with water, as they'd protected themselves by covering their body with a layer of spiritual energy that reflected the water.

"I-I'm so sorry!" Yu Rou apologized to them afterward.

"It's okay... I'm not that wet." Xia Jingyi said with a smile on her face.

"That's the technique you had chosen? Creating a tornado? This is my first time seeing such a unique technique," said Yuan.

"I thought it was a pretty neat technique and would complement my Wind Blades well, so I picked it." Yu Rou nodded.

"What about your second technique?" Yuan then asked.

"Uhh... It's also a wind technique, and it allows me to control the wind around me, allowing me to fly," she said.

"Fly? You can do that just by reaching Spirit Grandmaster or Spirit Master if you're lucky," said Yuan.

"Just by reaching Spirit Grandmaster? Are you listening to yourself right now, brother? Do you think everybody is talented like you? Don't make it

sound so easy. It took the majority of the playerbase two to three months to reach Spirit Warrior, much less Spirit Grandmaster. It'll probably take us another 2 to 3 years if not even more to reach Spirit Grandmaster. Even if it'll take less than a year for me to reach Spirit Grandmaster, I think it's still worth learning this technique, since it will let me fly right after I learn the technique, which definitely won't take me a few years to learn— I hope..."

"I see... that makes sense." Yuan nodded.

"Anyways, Jingyi is still studying her technique, so let's wait until she finishes before we decide what we want to do next." Yu Rou said a moment later.

"I'm sorry for holding you guys back... You don't have to wait for me if you don't want to," she sighed.

"Nonsense! We started this together, so we're going to finish it together!" Yu Rou said, and she continued, "In the meantime, I will try to study my second Heaven-rank technique, so take your time."

"You don't mind right, brother? Meixiu?" Yu Rou asked them.

"I don't mind. I am still studying my technique as well." Yuan said.

"I also don't mind it. It just means I get to practice my movement technique even more." Meixiu said.

"Alright. Then it's decided."

Sometime later, Yuan, Yu Rou, and Xia Jingyi returned to their technique while Meixiu continued to practice with Xiao Hua.

As for Lan Yingying, she sat beside the lake with a Fiery Lotus floating on her palms and her eyes closed, almost like she was experiencing enlightenment, but in reality, she was just focused on keeping the Fiery Lotus from disappearing for as long as her spiritual energy allows.

They continued this for another five days until Xia Jingyi finally learned her technique.

"I did it!" Xia Jingyi exclaimed in an excited voice when she saw the notification.

"Hm? Did you finally learn the technique?" Yu Rou stopped studying her technique and turned to look at Xia Jingyi, who was sitting right beside her.

"Yes!" Xia Jingyi nodded.

"Congratulations. What kind of technique did you learn?" Yuan asked her.

"Oh, it's just another zither technique." Xia Jingyi said as she retrieved her zither that was an Earth-grade treasure.

Ting!

A crisp noise resounded, and a single arc of light that resembled Yu Rou's Wind Blade technique flew from the zither before flying towards the water in the lake.

Whoosh!

The water in the lake separated into two halves for a good second, looking like someone had created a path in the lake with a sword.

"Wow! What a powerful attack!" Yu Rou said. "So one of your techniques damages enemies internally and one slices them like swords?"

"Yes, pretty much." Xia Jingyi nodded.

Sometime later, Yu Rou asked everyone, "Now that we have new techniques, what should we do? I kind of want to test out these techniques on some magical beasts. Let's go do some quests again."

"I don't mind." Xia Jingyi nodded.

"I'm also down," Yuan said.

"Me too." Meixiu also said.

"Then let's go!"

Thus, they began making their way back to Seashell City for more quests.

Meanwhile, a few hundred thousand miles away from Yuan's location, Feng Yuxiang approached a large temple that was located at the peak of a large mountain.

"Who are you? And why have you come to our Mount Hua Temple?"

A group of bald monks approached Feng Yuxiang when they saw her approaching figure.

"I heard that my good friend Li Shizhen is currently here, so I am here to visit him," said Feng Yuxiang.

The bald monks had a look of surprise on their faces for a split second before they frowned and said, "There is nobody named Li Shizhen here! Please leave!"

However, Feng Yuxiang stayed there with a calm look on her face and said, "The person who gave me this information wouldn't dare to lie to me, or he'd risk eating a sword with his a.s.s. I know Li Shizhen is inside. I can even smell the scent of medicine from here."

The bald monks exchanged looks with each other before retrieving the staff strapped to their backs and pointing them at Feng Yuxiang.

"Leave!"

These bald monks all emitted the power of Spirit Masters. However, in the face of a peak Spirit Grandmaster like Feng Yuixang, the pressure they emitted was nonexistent.

Feng Yuxiang sighed and said, "I will give you one last chance to call Li Shizhen out for me. I don't want to cause any trouble for my Young Master, but he needs to see a doctor, and I promised him that I will find the best one for him."

"I know the Mount Hua Temple has a million-year history in the Lower Heavens, but if I have to tear down this place to get to Li Shizhen, I will do it."

However, the bald monks remained adamant on keeping Feng Yuxiang out of the temple.

"Leave! The person you are looking for is elsewhere! Even if you are heaven itself, you will have to leave!"

Feng Yuxiang raised her eyebrows.

The monks at Mount Hua Temple are usually very reasonable and calm. Why are they acting so suspicious?

Feng Yuxiang pondered for a moment and then came to a realization.

"Oh, I know. One of your top monks must be in some sort of life-or-death medical condition, and Li Shizhen is healing that person right now. Whenever he is healing someone, he forbids anyone from disturbing him until he's done. Is that why you're not letting me disturb him?"

"This is..."

The monks were speechless, as Feng Yuxiang's guess was spot on!

"How long do I have to wait? If you don't tell me, I will be mad," she said to them a moment later.

However, Li Shizhen was not only healing one of their valued monks but he also instructed them to keep his location a secret no matter what.

And they rather listen to Li Shizhen, who has the sick monk's life on his hands.

"We will not repeat ourselves! Li Shizhen is not here!" One of the monks suddenly said.

"Is that so?" Feng Yuxiang mumbled in a low voice before she closed her eyes.

After a moment of silence, Feng Yuxiang snapped open her eyes that had turned golden.

She then released her Spirit Grandmaster cultivation before shouting in a booming voice that shook the entire mountain.

"Li Shizhen! How long do you plan on making this pitiful young lady wait out here in the cold?! My body is freezing! If I die from hypothermia, I will definitely haunt you for the rest of your worthless life!"

The bald monks were speechless, but before they could even react, the doors to the temple opened in a forceful manner, and a handsome middle-aged man could be seen standing there with a terrified look on his face.

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Chapter 473 - Li Shizhen

"M-Madam Feng! What are you doing here?!" The handsome middle-aged man exclaimed when he saw Feng Yuxiang's beautiful figure standing not far away from the temple.

"Hmph! I have been looking everywhere for you, Li Shizhen! How dare you make me do so much work?" Feng Yuxiang sneered coldly.

"M-Master Li!" The bald monks were shocked when Li Shizhen actually came outside after hearing Feng Yuxiang's voice.

Is she really that important to him? Just who is this fierce woman with a domineering aura that resembles powerful magical beasts?

Li Shizhen looked at the monks and said, "Don't worry, I have stabilized the Head Monk's condition. He only needs to rest now."

"Thank you, Savior!"

The monks there immediately lowered their heads and bowed to him with gratitude.

"Let my friend over there through." Li Shizhen then said.

"Right away!"

The monks no longer blocked her path and allowed her entrance.

"Should have done this in the beginning," she said as she walked past them.

Once she entered the temple, Li Shizhen brought her to the guest room and served her tea.

"This is the first time you've personally looked for me. Did something happen? Do you need someone to be healed as soon as possible?" Li Shizhen asked her after they sat down.

"Not really. I want to introduce you to someone. He needs your help," she said.

"Who? Did you finally find a husband after so many years?" Li Shizhen joked.

Feng Yuxiang narrowed her eyes and stared at him with a dangerous look.

"I guess you didn't learn from the last time, or maybe you forgot about it. How about I stick a rod up your a.s.s to help you remember? This temple should have plenty of them," she then said in a cold voice.

Li Shizhen immediately began sweating, and he said with a stiff smile on his face, "Please have mercy. I still have nightmares about that incident."

"Hmph. Although this person isn't my husband, he's a very precious person to me," she answered him regardless after a moment of silence.

"Precious? Now my curiosity has peaked. Tell me more." Li Shizhen said.

"He's my Young Master," she said.

Pft!

Li Shizhen suddenly turned his head away from Feng Yuxiang before spitting out the tea in his mouth.

After coughing for a moment, he looked at her with disbelief in his eyes.

"Y-Young Master?"

"Yes, I have accepted him as my Master," she said.

Li Shizhen's jaw dropped, and he said, "Heavens... A Divine Beast— A phoenix, no less, has accepted a Master in the Lower Heavens? This is

unprecedented."

Li Shizhen was one of the very few people in the Lower Heavens that knew of Feng Yuxiang's real identity.

"What's so special about this Young Master of yours?" Li Shizhen then asked.

"You will know once you meet him. When can you leave this place? It's already been a week since I left his side. I don't want to make him wait any longer."

"Hmm... That is a tricky question. As much as I'd like to leave now, I still have a patient here, and you know that I cannot leave until I am certain that he's fine."

"What? I thought you said that you'd already stabilized his condition." Feng Yuxiang frowned.

"His condition has only stabilized. There are still many things that have to be done before he's cured. Unless you happen to have a Seven Colored Herb, then I can heal him and leave with you by today."

"Seven Colored Herb? I think my Young Master might have one," she said, recalling how he asked for its price before.

"Really?!" Li Shizhen was immediately filled with excitement.

Then he frowned, "Or are you saying that just to trick me into following you?"

"Even if my Young Master has a Seven Colored Herb, he has no reason to give it to you," she said.

"Three days. If you are not done by then, I will make you leave by force." Feng Yuxiang said.

Li Shizhen smiled and said, "Three days should be more than enough. Have you forgotten who I am? I don't hold the title Divine Doctor without a

reason."

"Whatever. I'm going to go look around the place until you're done."

"Just don't cause any troubles for the monks." Li Shizhen said.

Feng Yuxiang didn't say anything back and left the guest room.

"Madam Feng... She has gotten softer... Is this the effect of this mysterious Young Master of hers?" Li Shizhen mumbled to himself after Feng Yuxiang left.

Three days passed by in a flash, and Feng Yuxiang went to look for Li Shizhen to force him to leave with her if he wasn't done.

"I don't dare to make you look for me for a second time." Li Shizhen's voice suddenly resounded behind her.

"Are you done?" she asked him.

He nodded and said, "Yes. The Head Monk will make full recovery by next week."

And then he asked, "Where are we going now?"

"The Eastern Continent."

Thus Feng Yuxiang and Li Shizhen left the temple shortly after, heading towards the nearest city with a teleport device, and they proceeded to teleport from city to city until they reached the Eastern Continent a few days later.

After reaching the Eastern Continent, Feng Yuxiang said, "If you can help my Young Master, I will forget about the debt you owe me."

"Really?!" Li Shizhen looked at her with pure bliss on his face.

"Only if you help him. If you turn out to be useless, I will make you pay that debt immediately."

Li Shizhen swallowed nervously after hearing that.

"As long as it is related to medicine..." Li Shizhen said.

After traveling for another day, Feng Yuxiang and Li Shizhen arrived at Seashell City.

"Seashell City, huh? It's been over a hundred years since I last visited this city. The last time I did, it was to cure the city lord." Li Shizhen reminisced his history with this place.

"Follow me. I can sense the Young Master aura from here." Feng Yuxiang said as she began approaching the city.

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Chapter 474 - Divine Doctor

"Thank you for your help. Here are 500 gold coins for the trouble." An old lady handed Yu Rou the reward for completing her quest.

"Thank you."

After accepting the gold coins, Yu Rou left the store and grouped up with Yuan and the others waiting outside.

"How many quests have we completed in the last few days? I lost count at 21," said Yuan.

"I don't know, but we earned a lot of gold coins— at least if we compare ourselves to the majority of the playerbase." Yu Rou said.

"What do you want to do now? Continue doing quests?"

"I think we should take a break from quests and do something more relaxing. Let's go to a restaurant and have some food." Yu Rou suggested.

"That sounds great." Yuan nodded.

However, before they could go anywhere, a familiar voice resounded from the sky, and two figures descended from the heavens a moment later, shocking the pedestrians there.

"Young Master, I am back!" Feng Yuxiang called out to him from the sky as she descended.

"That's your Young Master?" Li Shizhen raised his eyebrows with a surprised look on his face after sensing Yuan's Spirit Grandmaster cultivation base.

He knew someone who could make Feng Yuxiang lower herself to become a servant wouldn't be an ordinary person, but to think he was a Spirit Grandmaster at such a young-looking age; it was quite shocking, especially since this is the Lower Heavens.

"Feng Feng?" Yuan smiled when he saw her beautiful face.

"They're flying..." Xia Jingyi mumbled in a dazed voice as she stared at them with disbelief on her face.

"I'm sorry for making you wait this long, Young Master. Please forgive me." Feng Yuxiang said to him after landing on the ground.

"Why are you apologizing? I should be thanking you instead." Yuan said.

He then turned to look at the handsome middle-aged man standing beside her and said, "Hello, you must be the doctor Feng Feng told me about."

'Feng Feng?' Li Shizhen laughed inwardly when he heard this cute nickname for Feng Yuxiang.

He wanted to try saying it too, but he didn't dare to actually say it out loud, as that might result in a sword violating his b.u.t.t.

Li Shizhen then responded with a friendly smile on his face, "Good morning, Young Master. My name is Li Shizhen, also known as Divine Doctor Li. I was told by Madam Feng here that you wanted to speak with me? Are you sick?"

Yuan nodded and said, "Yes, I wanted to speak with you. Can we go somewhere more private before we continue?"

"Most certainly. I know the perfect place." Li Shizhen said.

Yuan then turned to Yu Rou and the others before speaking, "I'm sorry, but can you guys go ahead without me? I have some business to take care of now."

"Is everything okay, brother?" Yu Rou asked him with a worried look on her face.

"Yes, everything is fine. I am just asking him for advice. I will tell you everything later."

"If you say so... Then we'll see you later, brother."

"Xiao Hua, can you stay with them just in case anything happens?" Yuan said to her before they left.

"Okay." Xiao Hua nodded.

"Thank you."

Yu Rou left the scene with Xia Jingyi and Meixiu a moment later, followed by Xiao Hua.

"Shall we go now?" Li Shizhen asked him.

"Yes, let's go." Yuan nodded.

Li Shizhen proceeded to take Yuan to a nearby medicine store. In fact, it was one of the biggest and most popular medicine stores in the city.

When the manager of that store saw Li Shizhen's face, he immediately kowtowed on the floor.

"Welcome to our humble establishment, Divine Doctor Li!"

Even though he had never personally met Li Shizhen before, there was not a single doctor in the Lower Heavens that didn't know of Li Shizhen.

"Do you mind if we use one of your private rooms for a bit?" Li Shizhen asked him with a friendly smile.

"Please! Stay however long you want! I will even close the store until you leave so that there will be no distraction!" The manager said.

"It's okay, you don't have to do so much. And for allowing us to use your place, I will give every doctor in this place an hour lecture if you wish."

"Thank you! Thank you very much!" The manager began crying when he heard that Li Shizhen will be giving them a lecture.

To receive a lecture from the Divine Doctor, even if it's just an hour, they will remember this for the rest of their life, and they can wear this achievement with pride.

Yuan was left speechless after witnessing this scene, and he could only imagine how much of a big shot Li Shizhen was.

Sometime later, Yuan and the others entered this private room somewhere inside the medicine store.

"Have a seat." Li Shizhen said.

Once they were seated, Feng Yuxiang said, "Before we start, let me give you some background about Li Shizhen and why you can trust him."

"Li Shizhen holds the title of Divine Doctor, a prestigious title that can only be held by the best doctors in the Nine Heavens, and although he's currently staying in the Lower Heavens, Li Shizhen is actually from the upper heavens."

"What? Really?" Yuan looked at Li Shizhen with a surprised expression.

Li Shizhen nodded and said, "There are plenty of Divine Doctors in the upper heavens while the Lower Heavens lacked one, so I willingly came down here to help those in need of it. I even restricted my cultivation base to the peak of Spirit Grandmaster so that I can stay here without any problems."

"I have wandered around the Lower Heavens for over 1,000 years now, and I do not plan on returning to the upper heavens anytime soon, as there are still a lot of people who are in need of a good doctor in the Lower Heavens."

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Chapter 475 - The Reason for His Condition

"By the way, I have over 10,000 years of experience in the field of medicine, and there hasn't been a single patient that I haven't been able to cure since I became a doctor." Li Shizhen said.

Yuan nodded, "I will trust you."

Though it was not like he never trusted Li Shizhen.

Even if Li Shizhen didn't say any of that, Yuan would've still trusted him, as he was someone that Feng Yuxiang trusted enough to approach.

"Great. Now then, why don't you tell me what seems to be troubling you?" Li Shizhen asked him a moment later.

Yuan took a deep breath and proceeded to explain his situation to Li Shizhen without telling Li Shizhen that he was the person on the topic.

"I have this friend who grew incredibly sick out of the blue when he was young, and he has been crippled since then."

"Everything seemed to be normal for the first seven years of his life, but then he suddenly lost his ability to see, becoming blind. Five years later, his body suddenly stopped functioning, so everything below his neck became useless and numb to feeling, forcing him to stay in the bed."

"However, when the doctors checked his condition, they weren't able to find anything wrong with his body. They checked his blood, his muscles, and even his bones, but they were unable to find anything."

"The doctors said that he was perfectly healthy, yet he was unable to move."

"However, after 5 gruesome years, my friend finally started recovering after he started cultivating. He started feeling his body again, and now he can even move his limbs slightly."

"He's also a peak Spirit Warrior on the verge of breaking through to Spirit Master, but he still feels as though his body doesn't have any strength to it. He can feel his body overflowing with energy, but he cannot exert any of that energy. Do you have any idea what's wrong with him and if there's any cure that will allow him to recover faster?"

"Hmmm... Give me a moment to think about this..." Li Shizhen said to him before closing his eyes and turning silent.

Many minutes later, he opened his eyes and spoke in a calm voice, "This is an interesting case— not to make fun of your friend. I have seen many cases similar to this, but there are some distinctive differences."

"One such case being Qi deprivation. Once a cultivator reaches a certain cultivation base, they are required to continue absorbing spiritual energy to keep their bodies functioning, and if they stop absorbing spiritual energy for long enough, their bodies will slowly lose their functions. They will go blind, and their bodies will no longer be usable until they start absorbing spiritual energy again, just like your friend, but this only happens when the cultivator purposefully stops absorbing spiritual energy."

"As cultivators, we subconsciously absorb the spiritual energy around us even if we don't actively cultivate, so one must forcefully stop their bodies from absorbing spiritual energy, or something is preventing them from doing so."

"However, that isn't the case for your friend, as he's only a peak Spirit Warrior, meaning he's not at the level where they can experience Qi deprivation in such a manner. Furthermore, his problem began even before he started cultivating."

After taking a moment to breathe, Li Shizhen continued, "Now onto the second case— poison. There are powerful and deadly poisons out there that can have similar effects on humans if ingested. However, this is also unlikely for your friend, because you said that the doctors have checked his blood."

"Even an incredibly incompetent doctor would be able to detect the poison in his blood if he'd ingested some. Although there are undetectable poisons out there, none of them could cause the effects your friend is experiencing — at least I am not aware of any."

Yuan nodded and said, "I also don't think it was caused by poison."

"Then onto the last probability and also the one that's most likely the cause of your friend's misfortune." Li Shizhen said.

"Curse. Your friend was cursed."

"W-What?" Yuan's eyes widened when he heard Li Shizhen's words.

"Your friend was cursed, hence why the doctors cannot find anything wrong within his body, as most of them do not have the capabilities to detect even the weakest curses. The field of medicine and curses are vastly different, so unless they're a Divine Doctor like me, they most likely won't know anything about curses."

"Another reason that supports this theory is the fact that despite being a Spirit Warrior and feeling energetic, your friend cannot exert any strength. Now the question is whether your friend was cursed by another individual or is it due to a natural curse." Li Shizhen pondered with a serious look on his face.

"..."

Yuan was speechless, and he recalled his conversation with Doctor Wang sometime ago. Although Doctor Wang also mentioned that he could be cursed, neither of them took such a theory seriously, as it was a ridiculous thought that curses could be real.

And even though cultivation was proven to be real, that doesn't prove curses were real. After all, even though cultivation existed in both Cultivation Online and the real world, magical beasts that also exist in Cultivation Online don't exist in the real world.

This meant that just because something existed in Cultivation Online, it doesn't always mean their world will also have it.

"Is there no other reason why my friend is like that?" Yuan couldn't help but ask.

"If he's not cursed then I don't have any idea what's wrong with your friend, as there's no illness that could affect one's body like what you explained to me. One could go blind due to illnesses, and one can even lose functions to their entire body due to illnesses, but to have a healthy body while having all of that problem just isn't possible."

"However, if your friend is cursed, then that would explain why his body is in that state despite being completely healthy, and that also explains why he started recovering when he started cultivating, as most curses have weakened effects on cultivators, especially the stronger they get." Li Shizhen said.

Chapter 476 – Northern Continent

"I am fairly certain that your friend is cursed, but if you want me to be 100 percent certain, then I'd need to see the patient so I can personally examine his condition." Li Shizhen suddenly said.

"Uhh..."

Li Shizhen's words took Yuan by surprise.

"I-I'm sorry, but that's impossible," he said a moment later.

"Impossible? Why?" Li Shizhen raised his eyebrows.

"My friend comes from a super secretive and strict family, so getting even close to him is near impossible. Furthermore, he lives in a place that's very, very far away from this place."

"Oh, and something happened to his family recently, so it's even more difficult to see him now..." Yuan made up some random excuse.

After all, it was not like he could tell Li Shizhen the truth about his situation, as he'd sound crazy.

"Is that so?" Li Shizhen doubted Yuan was telling him the truth, but he didn't say anything about it, as there must be a reason why Yuan was acting this way.

And he continued, "Well, I don't really need to see your friend since you told me that he's already recovering, and I have cured many people without even seeing them— only by listening to their condition and symptoms."

"Thank you for understanding. Anyway, if my friend is really cursed... Is there any way to remove this curse?" Yuan then asked.

"Why don't you just let him drink some of your blood, Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang spoke for the first time.

Yuan looked at her and sighed, "He's not like you, Feng Feng. He's human."

"But that shouldn't matter. I'm no expert, but your blood clearly has the ability to weaken curses. It shouldn't have anything to do with being a human or not."

Li Shizhen then said, "Your blood has the ability to weaken curses? I have never heard of this before. How are you so sure his blood has such abilities, Madam Feng?"

Feng Yuxiang then explained to him about her condition, "I drank his blood and the curse on me weakened, so I know it works."

"What? Is that true? Your curse weakened?" Li Shizhen looked at her with wide eyes.

"Yes. Why would I lie about this?" Feng Yuxiang nodded.

"Heavens..." Li Shizhen mumbled in a dumbfounded voice.

"Anyways, since your blood has capabilities to weaken curses, as weird as this is going to sound, if you let your friend drink your blood, it could possibly work."

Yuan showed a bittersweet smile on his face.

Does this mean he'll have to drink his own blood? Even though he already has such blood flowing inside his body? This doesn't make any sense to him.

"I-I understand... But what if that doesn't work?" Yuan then asked.

"Are there any more natural methods for getting rid of curses?"

"Hmm... I may have some knowledge regarding curses, but I know someone who's an expert with curses. If you'd like, I can take you to him so you can ask him yourself. He's not that far away from this place. We can get there in just a few hours."

Yuan pondered for a moment before nodding, "Okay, just give me a minute to let the others know."

He then spoke to Xiao Hua through their servant and master connection.

"Xiao Hua, I am going to go meet someone with Feng Feng and the Divine Doctor, and we have to leave the city for a while. Let Yu Rou and the others know, okay? I will try to return as soon as possible."

Xiao Hua's voice resounded a moment later, "Okay, Xiao Hua will let them know."

"Thank you."

"Alright. We can go now." Yuan then said Li Shizhen.

Sometime later, they went downstairs.

"Don't worry, I will return later to give you guys the lecture." Li Shizhen said to the manager of the store before they left.

"We will be fine even if the Divine Doctor cannot lecture us. We know you're a busy man, after all." The manager said.

"When I, Li Shizhen, say that I will do something, I will do it!" He declared in a domineering voice.

The manager and the others in the store had nothing else to say after hearing such words, so they could only lower their heads and bow to him.

Once Li Shizhen left the store, the manager said to the others, "We're not going home until he returns even if it takes days!"

"Yes!" The others responded with anticipation in their voice.

Meanwhile, after leaving the medicine store, Yuan followed Feng Feng and Li Shizhen to another city that had a teleport formation.

During their trip, Yuan asked Li Shizhen, "If I heard correctly, you mentioned something about natural curses before. What did you mean by that? Can curses even occur naturally?"

Li Shizhen nodded and said, "I think it'd be better if the expert explained it, but yes, curses can occur naturally just like how treasures can be born naturally. However, they're considered a phenomenon— something akin to natural disasters. Of course, natural curses are incredibly rare and will only occur when certain conditions are met."

"I see..." Yuan nodded.

Sometime later, they entered a teleport device and teleported tens of thousands of miles in an instant.

After that, they used the teleport device again to teleport even further, as each teleport can only travel a limited distance.

They continued this six times before they finally stopped.

"Welcome to the Northern Continent, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang said to him with a smile on her face.

"The Northern Continent, huh? Now I only need to step onto the Southern Continent and the Western Continent so that I can say I'd explore the entire Lower Heavens," he said in a joking tone.

"Follow me. He lives in a secluded area deep inside the mountain valleys, so teleporting there is impossible." Li Shizhen said to them a moment later.

Yuan nodded, and they continued their journey to meet this expert on curses.

'An expert on curses, huh? I wonder what kind of person he's like...' Yuan wondered to himself as they soared into the sky.

Author's Note: I had intended to release these chapters sooner, but Hurricane Ida happened and delayed everything due to no power or internet. I am okay and will return to writing daily now.

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Chapter 477 – Embodiment Of Curses

After arriving at the Northern Continent and flying for around four hours, Yuan and the others arrived at this somewhat empty hill that only had a single small building, a tree, and a small pond beside the tree where three koi fishes can be seen swimming in circles.

Upon landing on this hill, Li Shizhen went to knock on the door.

However, nobody answered the door.

"Hmm... That man probably went fishing," Li Shizhen said a moment later.

"Fishing? This time of the day?" Yuan raised his eyebrows, as it was getting dark.

"Yes, he's a weirdo." Li Shizhen nodded.

"Who are you calling a weirdo, you slobby doctor?" A voice suddenly resounded.

The door to the building opened, and a short old man with a bald head walked outside the next moment.

"If you were here, why didn't you open the door? What took you so long?" Li Shizhen said with a frown on his face.

"I was taking a nap! If I didn't hear your annoying voice, I would've remained in bed!" The old man exclaimed in a somewhat angry voice.

"Hmm? Madam Feng? You're here as well?" The old man suddenly noticed Feng Yuxiang and immediately began smiling.

"How may I help you today, Madam Feng?"

Seeing the old man's attitude turn 180 when speaking with Feng Yuxiang, Li Shizhen shook his head.

"Damn old pervert," he snorted in a low voice.

"I am not the one who needs your help today. My Young Master needs your help." Feng Yuxiang said to him.

"What? Young Master?" The old man's eyes widened with shock.

He then turned to look at the third person there.

"Whoa! Holy heavens!"

When the old man saw Yuan, he suddenly took a step back and shouted in a terrified voice, acting like he just saw a ghost.

"Is there something wrong?" Yuan couldn't help but ask after seeing his reaction.

"S-Stay away from me!" The old man shouted at him before running back into the house and slamming the door shut, leaving Yuan dumbfounded.

Even Li Shizhen and Feng Yuxiang were left speechless by his reaction to seeing Yuan, as this was their first time seeing him acting in such a manner.

"What the heck is going on now, Zhai Ye?" Li Shizhen asked him.

"Fuck you, Li Shizhen! I should be asking you that! Are you trying to kill me?!" Zhai Ye shouted from inside the building, sounding really angry for some reason.

"What? Why would I want to kill you? Have you finally gone crazy from old age? We're here to talk about curses! This young man has a friend that

might be cursed, so we came here for your expertise!" Li Shizhen said, feeling really confused now.

"Hahaha! That's really funny! Because that young man you brought here is loaded with curses— powerful curses that even I didn't know could exist! He has so many curses that I wouldn't be surprised if he was the embodiment of curses!" Zhai Ye said, revealing his reason for his reaction.

"What? I'm filled with curses?" Yuan's eyes widened with shock.

Even Li Shizhen and Feng Yuxiang were shocked to hear this.

They turned to look at Yuan, but they couldn't see anything wrong with him.

"Come out here and explain yourself, Zhai Ye! I may not be as experienced with curses as you, but I can at least tell when someone is cursed, and I can't sense anything ominous coming from him!" Li Shizhen said with a frown on his face.

"What do you know, you amateur?! Have you forgotten about my special skill? I can tell whether someone is cursed or not at glance, no matter how weak or powerful the curse is!" Zhai Ye said.

Li Shizhen sighed.

He then asked Yuan, "Young Master, do you have any idea what he's talking about?"

Yuan pondered for a moment before realizing something.

"Ah! Do you mean the curse that's associated with my Legacy? I had accepted a Legacy recently, and the Legacy contained a small curse. It's a curse called Minor Misfortunate, and it only affects my luck," he said.

"You heard him, old man. It's only a Minor Curse. How can you be scared of a Minor Curse? I have never seen you act so fearful in front of a curse before!" Li Shizhen said to him a moment later, even laughing a bit.

After a moment of silence, the door opened slightly, and Zhai Ye peeked through the narrow space, but he didn't dare to come out.

He looked at Yuan with a serious expression on his face and said in a solemn voice, "You think I would be afraid of a mere Minor Curse when I have dealt with even Major Curses before? Young man, you have more than one curse on you right now. In fact, there's so many that I'm amazed you're still alive."

"Zhai Ye, explain yourself! What do you mean by that?!" Feng Yuxiang said with a deep frown on her face.

Zhai Ye then spoke, "Although the curse may be called 'Minor Misfortunate', it's actually a Major Curse. However, that curse might as well be a Minor Curse if not even lower compared to the other curses on him."

"There exist two types of curses in this world— artificial curses and natural curses. Artificial curses are caused by other humans whilst natural curses occur naturally if certain conditions are met. There are also many levels of curses. Minor, Major, Supreme, and Ancient, to name a few. The most common curses are naturally artificial curses."

"And as of this moment, I can see six... seven... perhaps even more curses on him, and they're all above Major Curses. However, that's not even the shocking part. These curses on him... they're all natural curses as far as I can tell."

"What?! Seven natural curses?! How is that even remotely possible?!" Li Shizhen exclaimed, not daring to believe his ears.

A single natural curse was already rare enough, much less seven! And they are all affecting a single person right now?

Yuan looked down at his own body. He also couldn't believe it. Why does he have so many natural curses on him?

Chapter 478 – Celestial Rank

Physique

"Young man, if you're here to look for my help, I am sorry, but I have to say that I am powerless against the curses on you. They're simply too powerful. I don't even dare to try to touch it, as it might worsen." Zhai Ye said to him a moment later.

"Is it really that serious? Isn't there anything you can do?" Feng Yuxiang didn't want to give up so easily, especially after learning how bad the situation really is.

"Madam Feng, do you remember when I tried to help you with your curse but was defeated in the end?" Zhai Ye suddenly asked her.

Many years ago, Feng Yuxiang had approached him for help regarding her curse.

"Of course. Even though you couldn't get rid of it, I still owe you greatly for your years of efforts." Feng Yuxiang nodded.

"I have encountered tens of thousands of curses throughout my life, but I have never experienced powerlessness until I met you, Madam Feng. Your curse was my first defeat. However, as powerful as your curse may be, I still dared to try and defeat it."

Zhai Ye then turned to look at Yuan and swallowed nervously.

"As for him... This is my first time experiencing fear. The curses on him terrify me so much that I do not even dare to approach him."

"I-It's okay. I understand your feeling." Yuan said to him.

"You don't need to touch the curses on me, but do you have any advice for me? How does one normally get rid of natural curses?" He then asked.

"That will depend on how you acquired those curses in the first place. Do you have any idea how you may have gotten those curses?" Zhai Ye said.

Yuan turned silent and began pondering to himself.

After thinking for many minutes, he still couldn't think of anything, so he shook his head.

"I cannot think of how I got these curses."

Feng Yuxiang then asked, "Zhai Ye, is it possible for natural curses to occur during birth? Like how some are born with powerful physiques while others are born without any physiques."

"Yes, if his ancestors were cursed and passed away without getting rid of the curse, there's a good chance that the curse might carry on to the future generations. However, there are only a handful of curses that are powerful enough to do such a thing, and this young man has more than just a handful of curses on him." Zhai Ye said.

"I see... Can you give me some examples of natural curses?" Yuan then asked.

"Let's say your ancestor killed a lot of people... enough people to create a mountain using their corpses. This could result in your ancestor getting cursed by the spirits of the dead people."

"..."

Hearing such an example, Yuan couldn't help but recall that one dream he had previously when he dreamt about killing a lot of people— enough people to create multiple mountains with their corpses and many rivers with their blood.

"Another case of a natural curse is when one is born with an extremely powerful physique and they invoke heaven's jealousy or wrath. When that

happens, the heavens might put a curse on that individual so that he doesn't affect the world too much. This has happened multiple times before in the upper heavens."

"Hm? A powerful physique? Young Master, I'd say your physique is pretty heaven-defying— enough to invoke heaven's jealousy. Maybe it's your physique that caused these natural curses?" Feng Yuxiang suddenly speculated.

"Really? What kind of physique do you have?" Li Shizhen asked him out of curiosity.

"The Heaven Refining Physique," he said.

"Never heard of it." Li Shizhen shook his head.

"What rank is it? Divine-rank?"

"No, it's Celestial-rank."

"D-Did you just say Celestial-rank?" Li Shizhen's eyes widened to the point where his eyeballs nearly rolled out of their sockets.

"Celestial-rank?" Feng Yuxiang had a different reaction, as she wasn't familiar with this grade.

"How high is that?" She then asked Li Shizhen, as he seemed to know judging by his reaction.

"T-The Celestial-rank is two ranks above the Mythic-rank..." Li Shizhen mumbled in a dazed voice.

"WHAT?!" Feng Yuxiang and Zhai Ye exclaimed in a shocked voice afterward.

"Two ranks above the Mythic rank?! I didn't know it went that high!" Feng Yuxiang then said.

"Of course you wouldn't know about it. It only exists in the Seventh Heaven and above!" Li Shizhen said.

And he continued, "I only know about it because I once read about it in an ancient scroll from the Eighth Heaven!"

"Ridiculous... Why is someone like that in the Lower Heavens? Where did you find this monster?" Zhai Ye said in a dumbfounded tone.

"That's rude of you, Zhai Ye! And I didn't find the Young Master! He found me!" Feng Yuxiang said.

"Anyways, I think I understand why you have so many natural curses. A Celestial-rank physique is something that could definitely invoke jealousy from the heavens. The stronger your physique— even bloodline— the more the heavens will try to hinder you. However, if you manage to overcome the heavens' jealousy, you will become unstoppable..." Li Shizhen said a moment later.

"I have never seen anyone with a Celestial-rank physique before, but to invoke over seven natural curses... I cannot imagine what could happen once you get rid of those curses holding you back."

"Wait, can you tell what kind of effects these curses have on me?" Yuan suddenly asked him.

Zhai Ye shook his head and said, "I can only tell you what kind of curses they are, but I do not know the details."

He then stared at Yuan for a few more moments before speaking, "Most of these curses are restriction curses, but there are a few that I cannot tell at all. Furthermore, there is a high probability that there are more than seven curses on you and I just cannot see them even with my special talent."

"Since it's likely that these curses are caused by your physique, then there's only one way to undo them— by tempering your physique."

"Tempering my physique...?" Yuan mumbled to himself. This is his second time hearing this phrase, with Xu Jiaqi mentioning it before.

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Chapter 479 – Treasures In The Real World

"I have heard it before, but what does it mean to 'temper' my physique?" Yuan asked Zhai Ye a moment later.

"There are a couple of methods you can use to temper your body, but the most common ones are bathing in liquefied treasure and cultivating in a special area that affects your body." Zhai Ye said.

"Bathing in liquefied treasure, huh?" Yuan repeated to himself.

"I understand the first one, but what about the second method? What kind of special area do I have to cultivate in? Do you have any examples?"

"There are multiple phenomenal places in the cultivation world, such as a mountain that has extreme Yang Qi, and if you have a physique that benefits from Yang Qi, you can cultivate there to temper your body. Another example is a place called the Frozen Sea where it releases extremely pure Yin Qi, so females with a special Yin Physique would go there to temper their body."

"Some methods are stress-free while others are incredibly painful. This should be obvious, but the stronger your physique, the more resources you'll need to temper it, and in your case... you'll probably have to go to hell and back... multiple times in order to temper your body."

Yuan nodded and said, "Returning to the first method... Are there treasures out there specifically for tempering one's body? Or can I just use any treasure for the bath?"

"There are specific treasures out there for body tempering, Young Master. In fact, I have some with me. We can try it later." Feng Yuxiang suddenly said.

"Really?!" Yuan immediately became elevated upon hearing her words.

"Yes. Just let me know when you want to do it." Feng Yuxiang nodded.

"Let's do it tomorrow, then!"

"Okay."

Sometime later, Zhai Ye said, "If you got nothing else for me, can you leave? I am barely keeping my sanity just by being around you."

"S-Sorry... We'll leave right now. And thank you very much for your help, senior." Yuan bowed to him.

"Do you still need me around?" Li Shizhen then asked.

"If not, I will stay around for a little more, and I still have to give a lecture to the doctors back at the medicine store," he said.

"No, you can leave. Thank you for everything as well. I will definitely repay this debt in the future." Yuan bowed to him too.

"You don't have to repay me. I am a Divine Doctor. I don't accept payments for my assistance. And I didn't really do anything— only giving you some advice." Li Shizhen said.

"Still, I want to thank you for helping me greatly."

Li Shizhen nodded and then said, "Very well. How about this? If your friend's condition gets better because of this, I will accept your gratitude."

"Okay!" Yuan said.

"Let's go, Feng Feng," Yuan said to her before flying back to the nearest city with a teleport device.

Once they were gone, Zhai Ye opened the door and walked outside again.

"What more do you want from me?" He asked Li Shizhen.

Li Shizhen smiled and said, "Wanna have a drink? It's been a decade since we last sat down together, after all."

"I hope you brought something strong— strong enough for me to forget about that little monster," said Zhai Ye.

"Of course."

The two of them entered the building and began drinking alcohol.

Meanwhile, after they arrived at the city, Yuan said, "Feng Feng, I am going to retire today. I will see you tomorrow early in the morning."

"Okay. Rest well, Young Master."

Once Feng Yuxiang entered his body, Yuan logged off the game.

When Yuan logged off, dinner was already prepared by Meixiu.

"Meixiu, I am finished," he said to her.

"I'm coming." Meixiu entered his room a minute later with dinner.

Yuan wanted to tell her about everything that happened today, but Meixiu insisted that he finished dinner first.

After dinner, Meixiu cleaned the dishes before going back to his room and taking a seat beside his bed.

"Alright. What happened?" she asked him.

"You won't believe what happened today, Meixiu!" Yuan proceeded to tell her everything Li Shizhen and Zhai Ye had told him.

"You're cursed?" Meixiu wasn't sure how to react after listening to his story.

"Do curses even exist in our world?" she couldn't help but wonder this question out loud.

"I can only think of one instance where curses are mentioned in this world... When I asked Yu Rou about playing the zither in this world before, she told me that people used to use them many years ago, but people eventually stopped playing zither because of some curse."

"Hmm... Give me a moment to look it up." Meixiu said before taking out her laptop and searching about the curse on the internet.

A minute later, she said, "According to the internet, people stopped playing the zither because bad luck would fall upon those who touch the zither. Almost all zither players experienced misfortune, and many of them even died in accidents— incredibly unfortunate ones. Once the news spread, people eventually stopped playing the zither out of fear."

"Heavens... I didn't think the zither would have such a history in our world. If curses really exist, then maybe I am really cursed." Yuan sighed.

"Even if curses are real... How are we supposed to deal with it? You may be able to bathe in treasures in Cultivation Online, but there are no such treasures in this world—" Meixiu suddenly stopped speaking midway through her sentence.

Then she started typing on her laptop.

A few minutes later, she said, "Looks like treasures actually exist in this world as well..."

"What?! Really?!" Yuan exclaimed in a shocked voice.

"Yes, and according to some people, they have treasures that contain spiritual energy with some even granting special effects such as increased

strength and hearing. However, compared to the treasures one can find in Cultivation Online, the treasures in this world are much weaker."

"What do these treasures look like?" Yuan then asked.

"Well, they're mostly antiques and ancient medicine from the past," she said.

After pondering for a moment, Yuan said, "Do you think we will be able to buy some of these treasures to see for ourselves?"

"Well... They're incredibly expensive with most of them going for millions of dollars. However, we should be able to afford them." Meixiu nodded.

"Then let's buy some. If we don't have enough money, we can simply sell some things in the auction house again. Where can we buy them?"

"Give me a minute..."

After looking on the internet for a few minutes, Meixiu spoke, "Looks like we can either buy them online or in real auction houses. People recommend buying them in person since there are many scammers out there."

"Real auction houses, huh. Let's wait a few more weeks before we go outside. Hopefully, the Cultivators' Association will give up on you soon." Yuan said.

"Okay. I will do more research on this topic in the meantime."

Sometime later, before Meixiu went back to her own room to cultivate, Yuan said to her, "Meixiu, can you grab a knife from the kitchen and leave it on a chair beside my bed?"

"Huh? Why?" She couldn't help but ask after hearing such a weird request.

"Well... I have been thinking... If cultivation techniques from Cultivation Online work in our world, what about the other techniques? I want to try it out."

"Other techniques...? Now that you mention it..." Meixiu was dumbfounded after realizing that too.

"But does it have to be a knife? That's very dangerous... What if you hurt yourself?" she said in a worried voice afterward.

"Don't worry, I am just experimenting to see if it actually works or not. I won't do anything crazy," he promised her.

"Okay..." Meixiu then went outside to grab a clean kitchen knife and a chair before placing the knife on the chair beside the bed in Yuan's room.

Meixiu then proceeded to stare at the knife for a good minute before deciding that it would be better for her to stay in the room just in case anything happens.

"Yuan, I am going to stay here tonight just in case," she said to him.

"Okay. I don't mind," he quickly agreed.

She then took a seat on the other side of the bed and started her cultivation.

Meanwhile, Yuan prepared himself.

After taking deep breaths, he began trying to recall the Flying Dagger technique that he was very used to by now.

However, whether the Flying Dagger technique will work on a kitchen knife or not is an entirely different story.

A few minutes later, Yuan successfully recited the full technique inside his head.

Now it was time for the moment of truth— whether it works or not.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan used his Divine Sense to locate the knife sitting a few meters besides him.

Once he located it, he tried to use Flying Daggers on it like he normally would in Cultivation Online.

A moment later, the kitchen knife resting on the chair suddenly began to tremble, and he could feel an invisible connection to the knife.

Yuan immediately became excited when he saw this, but the moment he lost focus, the connection disappeared and the knife stopped moving.

'It actually works! Let's try that again just in case I was only imagining it!'

With that in mind, he started using Flying Daggers on the kitchen knife again.

This time, even though he was certain that the kitchen knife was moving, he didn't lose focus.

A few moments later, the kitchen knife that had been sitting on the chair suddenly began levitating off the chair!

It was flying! Yuan had successfully used Flying Daggers in the real world!

Chapter 480 – A Work Of Art

"Hahaha! It works! It really works!" Yuan suddenly started laughing from sheer excitement when the Flying Daggers technique worked in the real world.

"Huh?" Meixiu stopped cultivating when she heard his laughter and turned to look at the chair.

Her eyes widened with surprise when she saw the kitchen knife she used for dinner floating above the chair, almost like a magic trick.

However, unlike a magic trick, there were no invisible strings attached to the knife.

"Meixiu, look! It works! It's not just cultivation techniques! Even martial techniques from Cultivation Online work in our world!" Yuan said to her.

"Yes... I can see that..." She mumbled in a dazed voice.

A few moments later, the kitchen knife stopped floating and fell back onto the chair seat.

"Compared to Cultivation Online, it's actually harder to control it. I should have sufficient cultivation base to use Flying Daggers flawlessly, but I am having difficulties controlling it," he said a moment later.

"However, it's not as though I don't have enough spiritual energy. Unlike using Divine Sense, it's not exhausting, so I think it's just a matter of inexperience. Once I practice some more, I should be able to use Flying Daggers more skillfully."

Meixiu then said, "If you can use Flying Daggers... I wonder if there are any other cultivators that have succeeded—or how many have succeeded."

"I'm sure many people have tried to use martial techniques when they realized that cultivation techniques worked in the real world, but whether you succeeded or not is a different story," he said.

"There has been no news about this yet, but there's a good chance that some people have succeeded and are purposefully keeping it a secret. It's only a matter of time before someone lets the cat out of the bag like the situation with cultivation techniques." Meixiu agreed with him.

"Anyways, I am going to continue practicing this technique. If it's distracting, you can return to your own room to cultivate. I promise you that I won't do anything crazy so you can rest assured." Yuan said to her.

"Okay." Meixiu nodded and returned to her room.

Yuan proceeded to practice the Flying Daggers technique until it was morning.

After breakfast, Meixiu asked him, "Are you going to be with us today?"

"Yes, we will see you in a bit."

"Where do you want to meet?"

"Can you meet us at the Cultivators' Haven?" Yuan asked.

"Okay. I will let them know."

Once they entered Cultivation Online, Meixiu proceeded to wait for Yu Rou and the others while Yuan and Feng Yuxiang made their way back to Seashell City using the teleport device.

When they finally arrived at the city, Yuan and Feng Yuxiang went straight to the Cultivators' Haven, where Meixiu and the others could be seen idling around.

"Yu Rou!" Yuan called out to them.

"Welcome back, brother!" Yu Rou ran to him with a smile on her face.

"Are you okay? What happened yesterday? Where did you go?" She then bombarded him with questions.

A stiff smile appeared on Yuan's face.

Although he promised to tell her about everything once he returned, he wasn't sure about telling her that he was cursed, as that would definitely make her worried about him.

"I will tell you later," he decided to delay it for now.

He then turned to look at Feng Yuxiang and said, "I am ready."

Feng Yuxiang nodded.

"Let's rent a hotel room. We will need a bathtub for your tempering," she then said.

"A bathtub? Tempering?" Yu Rou and the others were quite puzzled, but they didn't ask any questions for now and decided to follow Feng Yuxiang and Yuan.

Once they were at the best hotel in the city, they rented out a room with the biggest bathtub.

Inside the bathroom with the bathtub, Feng Yuxiang filled the bathtub with hot water before heating the already hot water even further— until the water was literally boiling.

"Uhhh..." Yuan swallowed nervously when he saw this.

'I am supposed to bathe in this boiling hot water? That sounds... painful...' He thought to himself.

"Are you going to temper your body, Brother Yu— Tian?" Xiao Hua asked him after realizing what they were planning on doing.

"Yes, I am."

"..."

Xiao Hua was kind of speechless, as this was quite sudden.

Why did he suddenly decide to temper his body?

Sometime later, Feng Yuxiang retrieved a dozen treasures and began tossing them inside the bathtub with the boiling water, quickly turning the clear water green.

"Alright, Young Master. You just need to bathe in this water and absorb the treasures now. However, I have to warn you that it's going to be painful."

"Of course it's going to be painful! You're telling him to jump in boiling water!" Yu Rou said with a worried frown on her face.

Feng Yuxiang laughed out loud after hearing her words, and she said, "The boiling water won't hurt the Young Master. Have you forgotten about his cultivation base? It's the treasures that will do the hurting!"

"Go ahead, Young Master. Try touching the water normally." Feng Yuxiang then said to him.

Yuan nodded and dipped one of his fingers into the boiling water, and to his surprise—

"It doesn't hurt at all! It's actually quite warm!" He exclaimed in a surprised voice.

"Really? Let me try..."

Yu Rou also dipped her finger into the hot water, but she had a different reaction.

"Ah! It burns!"

Feng Yuxiang shook her head and said, "The Young Master may not have physically tempered his body before, but his cultivation is high enough to naturally protect his body against boiling water."

"You could've told me before I tried..." Yu Rou sighed.

Sometime later, Yuan asked, "I just need to bathe in this water, right?"

"That's right." Feng Yuxiang nodded.

"Okay."

Hearing her confirmation, Yuan started taking his clothes off in a nonchalant manner while everyone was present.

"?!?!" Xia Jingyi's face flushed with redness when Yuan suddenly began stripping, as this is her first time seeing a fully naked man.

'Young Master's bare body... What a work of art...' Feng Yuxiang chuckled inwardly as she stared at his refined body with an intensive gaze.

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Chapter 481 – Body Tempering

Yu Rou and Meixiu's eyes widened when Yuan suddenly stripped without any warnings.

Although they have seen his naked body plenty of times by now since they had to clean his body, seeing the naked body of a cripple who cannot move and seeing the naked body of a fully functional person gave two different feelings.

"B-Brother! You should've at least warned us that you were going to strip! There are ladies in here!" Yu Rou quickly said to him.

"Huh?" Yuan raised his eyebrows in a puzzled manner, clearly ignorant about these kinds of situations.

In his mind, some boundaries between men and women didn't exist.

Although he has only seen one naked woman in his life— Lan Yingying, she didn't have such a reaction when they were both naked before, so he didn't think too much about it.

Furthermore, Yu Rou and Meixiu have seen his naked body countless times, and they have even touched it before when they had to clean his body, not to mention the number of times he bathed with Yu Rou.

Seeing Yuan's puzzled reaction and calm demeanor, Yu Rou realized that she never really taught him common sense when it comes to things between women and men. After all, she never thought he would need this kind of knowledge, and it would also be embarrassing for her to teach someone older than her these kinds of things.

"Forget it..." Yu Rou sighed.

Sometime later, Yuan entered the bathtub and sat in the center in the lotus position.

Despite the water still at boiling point, Yuan couldn't feel any pain, only comfort.

"I just need to cultivate and absorb the treasures in the water, right?" Yuan asked while looking at Feng Yuxiang.

"Yes." Feng Yuxiang nodded.

"Okay."

Yuan proceeded to take a deep breath before clearing his mind.

He then started cultivating.

However, the instant he started absorbing the treasure, he felt sharp pain all over his body, almost like there were swords and daggers poking his pores.

"Ah!"

Yuan cried out loud and immediately stopped absorbing the treasures, startling the people in there.

"Are you okay?" Yu Rou asked him.

"This is painful! It's like I am being pricked by needles all over my body!" He exclaimed.

Feng Yuxiang then said in a calm voice, "I warned you that it was going to be painful, Young Master. Body tempering isn't easy. There's a reason why there are so few body refiners in the cultivation world compared to ordinary cultivators since many people cannot endure the pain."

"Are there any ways to lessen the pain at the very least?" Yuan asked.

Feng Yuxiang shook her head, "Unfortunately, there are no easy ways out of this. You either endure it or give up. In fact, the pain will only intensify as

you continue to temper your body."

Yuan frowned when he heard this.

However, as much as he wanted to give up, he needed to get rid of the curses.

After taking a moment to calm down, Yuan tried to absorb the treasures again.

The sharp pain quickly returned, and Yuan gritted his teeth to endure the pain.

And just like Feng Yuxiang said, the pain only became worse the more he tried to absorb the treasures.

What felt like needles poking at his body at first now felt like there were needles entering his body through every pore that was absorbing the treasures.

The pain penetrated deeper and deeper in this body as time went on.

Yuan had to give up a few times due to the intense pain, but he would eventually try again.

Yu Rou and the others watched with nervous looks on their faces. Seeing Yuan in so much pain also made them experience imaginary pain all over their body.

"Feng Feng, how long does it normally take to temper one's body?" Yu Rou asked her.

"How long does he need to endure this?"

Feng Yuxiang looked at Yuan and said, "Since this is the Young Master's first time doing body tempering, I didn't use too many treasures— just enough to let him experience it. If he continues to absorb the treasures at his current rate, he should be done in a few hours."

"A few hours?!" Yu Rou was shocked.

She expected this to last only a couple of minutes at most. It was unimaginable that one needed to endure such pain for hours!

Feng Yuxiang smiled and said, "If you think a few hours are bad, imagine tempering your body for weeks, even years."

An hour into tempering his body, Yuan was beginning to adapt to the pain, but that didn't mean it wasn't painful any longer. In fact, the pain continued to worsen the longer he tempered his body.

"I-Is that blood?" Yu Rou suddenly noticed the water turning slightly red.

Feng Yuxiang nodded, "Yes, but you don't have to worry. It won't cause any permanent damage to his body."

"The Young Master has actually increased the rate he's absorbing the treasures. If he continues at this rate, he should be done after another hour."

And just like Feng Yuxiang predicted, after soaking in the bathtub of treasures, Yuan opened his eyes when he finished absorbing all of the treasure in the water.

Near the end, since he'd already absorbed most of the treasure by then, the pain was no longer as strong, allowing him to relax until the end.

"How are you feeling, Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang asked him.

"Exhausted... yet refreshed at the same time, almost like I'd been reborn," he said with a smile on his face.

"Congratulations on your first body tempering, Young Master," she said.

"Thank you."

Yuan then stood up from the bathtub.

However, the very next second, Xia Jingyi released a startled cry.

"Ah!"

"Huh?" Yuan turned to look at Xia Jingyi, whose face was fully flushed with redness, and she even had her hands covering her eyes.

Yu Rou and Meixiu's jaw dropped when they realized why Xia Jingyi reacted in such a manner.

"B-Brother! Quickly, turn around!" Yu Rou shouted at him in a panicked voice.

"What?" Yuan became even more puzzled, and he turned to look at Feng Yuxiang.

"Young Master..." Feng Yuxiang cleared her throat and pointed at the area between his legs, her face slightly rosy as well.

Seeing this, Yuan looked down at his body, and to his surprise, between his legs, there was something long and majestic pointing at the heavens.

Chapter 482 – Unable To Calm Down

'What the?'

Yuan was surprised to see the thing between his legs suddenly grow in size and become as stiff as a rock, as this was his first time experiencing such a phenomenon.

He turned to look at Feng Yuxiang and asked her in a calm voice, "What's happening to my body? Is this also the effect of the treasures?"

"I-I guess there was a treasure in there that improved one's stamina..." Feng Yuxiang said in a stiff voice, mostly because she also didn't expect that it'd result in Yuan's precious area getting 'more stamina' as well.

"Is this a bad thing or a good thing?" Yuan then asked.

"I think it will be fine... It should calm down later." Feng Yuxiang said with a nervous look on her face, silently hoping to herself that it'd calm down by itself.

"Okay." Yuan believed her and got out of the bathtub.

"..."

Yu Rou and Meixiu stared at Yuan's glistening body. Although they wanted to look away, they were unable to for some reason.

Meixiu then noticed Xiao Hua also staring at Yuan with a calm look on her face, yet there was a hint of intrigue within her innocent gaze.

After drying his body, Yuan wore his clothes again, but it felt different than usual, even a little uncomfortable with the way his body is currently reacting.

"This is uncomfortable and is somewhat inconvenient to walk around," said Yuan with a slight frown on his face while looking at the obvious bulge between his legs.

Feng Yuxiang swallowed nervously at the sight of the Yuan's bulge.

Despite being over 100,000 years old, she had zero experience in these kinds of situations.

"You can try cultivating to calm it down." Feng Yuxiang then suggested.

"I will do just that." Yuan nodded, and he left the bathroom shortly after.

He then took a seat in the middle of the room and began cultivating. Of course, since he was sitting down, it made the bulge in his pants even more obvious.

"This is super awkward..." Meixiu muttered in a low voice.

"Right? We have taken baths together for many years, so I have seen his naked body plenty of times, but I am still embarrassed by it." Yu Rou said in a somewhat bragging voice.

"Hm?"

Yu Rou suddenly turned to look at Xiao Hua, who started approaching Yuan for some reason.

Once she stood in front of him, Xiao Hua squatted down and stared at the bulging area with a profound look on her face.

"W-What are you doing?" Feng Yuxiang asked her in a dumbfounded voice.

Xiao Hua then pointed at the bulge and said, "Why is it like that? Xiao Hua has never seen anything like that before."

"Uhhh..."

Xiao Hua's innocent question left the others in the room speechless.

Turns out there was another person that was clueless about these kinds of topics besides Yuan in their group.

"That is what happens when your body is overly excited," Feng Yuxiang gave her a brief explanation without going into depth.

"Don't worry, it will go away soon," she then added.

Xiao Hua nodded and no longer paid attention to this phenomenon on Yuan's body.

Sometime later, Xia Jingyi spoke in a low voice, "Wow... The speed he's cultivating at is very astonishing... Is this because of his cultivation technique?"

"I guess you can say that..." Yu Rou nodded.

After spending a little over an hour cultivating, Yuan suddenly stopped and opened his eyes.

He then turned to look at Feng Yuxiang and said to her in a complaining tone, "Feng Feng, it's not working. I cannot even cultivate properly because it's very distracting down there. And I think it's starting to hurt as well..."

Feng Yuxiang began sweating when she heard this, and she wondered if the treasure was too powerful or if Yuan had absorbed too much of the treasure.

After all, normal cultivators would only be able to absorb a portion of the treasure while letting the rest go to waste.

If Yuan's godlike physique also allowed him to absorb more treasures than one normally could, it would make sense why his body hasn't calmed down yet.

"Feng Feng, what exactly did you use for my brother's bathwater?" Yu Rou decided to ask her.

Feng Yuxiang showed a nervous smile and said, "The treasure that's causing his condition is most likely the Endurance Yang Root; it's a very popular treasure among male body refiners since it refines their muscles and boosts their endurance. However, there's a slight side effect... And that being a slight aphrodisiac effect..."

"Aphrodisiac effect?! You made my brother absorb that kind of evil medicine?!" Yu Rou was speechless.

"I-I swear it wasn't done on purpose! Normally, one would only be able to absorb about ten to thirty percent of the treasures, so this side effect won't affect the person too much if any at all! However, I might have overlooked the Young Master's unique physique, hence this situation..."

"I'm sorry... I won't put something like that in the Young Master's bath again," she apologized.

"Don't worry about it, Feng Feng. I know you don't have any bad intentions. However, this is a problem. I can't move around like this. How long will this effect last before it naturally goes away?" Yuan then asked her.

"S-Seven days..." She muttered in a low voice.

"An entire week?!" Yuan exclaimed.

There was no way he'd be able to endure this an entire day, much less a whole week.

"Is there anything we can do to relieve it quicker?" Yuan then asked.

The room instantly turned silent, and the ladies turned to look at each other.

Clearly, none of them wanted to be the one to tell him.

After a moment of silence, Feng Yuxiang cleared her throat and spoke with her back straight, "Ahem! Since I am the reason the Young Master is in pain, I shall bear all responsibility."

She then turned to look at Yuan and said with a bashful expression on her beautiful face, "Please follow me to another room, Young Master. I will take care of it."

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Chapter 483 – Relieving His Pain

Contains mature content

Disclaimer: Read at your discretion. You can skip this chapter without needing to worry about missing key information about the story.

"W-Wait just a minute!" Yu Rou quickly stopped them.

"Is there something wrong?" Feng Yuxiang asked her.

"Of course! Everything is wrong! What do you think you're going to do to my brother's pure body?"

"Obviously, I am going to help him relieve his pain." Feng Yuxiang spoke in a calm voice and acted as though it was natural.

And she continued, "Unless you want to help him instead..."

Feng Yuxiang narrowed her eyes at Yu Rou, who trembled at the thought of 'relieving' Yuan.

"N-Nonsense! I am his sister! You're asking for the impossible!" She quickly refused.

Yu Rou then turned to look at Meixiu and said, "Meixiu, you do it! I trust you with Brother Tian's body more than I trust Feng Feng, after all!"

"What?" Meixiu looked at her with wide eyes and even took a step back from shock.

"Y-You want me to...? I don't think I can do something like that..." Meixiu quickly shook her head and refused.

Even though she had touched Yuan's divine sword before, it was necessary to clean him, and it wasn't done with any vulgar intentions.

Furthermore, she was too embarrassed to do it knowing there are people waiting for her to relieve him.

If she was alone with Yuan, perhaps she might reconsider.

"See? If nobody is willing to relieve the Young Master, I will have to be the one to bear this responsibility." Feng Yuxiang said with a quick shrug and a somewhat smug look on her face.

"Xiao Hua can help Brother Tian." Xiao Hua suddenly offered her assistance.

"..."

The others looked at her with raised eyebrows. Regardless of her real age, letting someone like Xiao Hua deal with this situation would cause outrage if known. Furthermore, Xiao Hua was as innocent as Yuan herself when it came to this topic, so even if they allowed her to help him, she wouldn't know what to do.

"I-It's okay, Xiao Hua. Let the adults bear this responsibility." Feng Yuxiang said to her.

Meanwhile, Yuan was absolutely clueless as to why they were arguing about this, as he just wanted to relieve this pain between his legs, so he didn't care who had to do it.

"Let's go, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang said to him.

"Feng Feng! Don't go overboard!" Yu Rou warned her with a serious frown.

Feng Yuxiang nodded before going to another room with Yuan, closing the door behind them.

The place quickly turned dead silent.

"I can't believe this is happening..." Xia Jingyi mumbled in a dazed voice after a moment of silence.

"I am going to go out and get some fresh air." Yu Rou said.

"I will come with you..." Meixiu followed her outside.

Xiao Hua looked at them with her eyebrows slightly raised, unable to comprehend why they were unhappy about Feng Yuxiang helping Yuan relieve his pain.

Meanwhile, inside the bedroom, Feng Yuxiang cleared her throat before speaking, "Young Master, please take off your clothes— just the lower part is fine."

Yuan nodded and obediently removed his pants. Although it felt a little weird, he didn't think too much about it, since this was only to cure his condition.

After taking off the lower part of his clothes, Yuan sat on the edge of the bed with his sword standing upright.

"Young Master, I am only doing this to help your condition, so excuse me in advance for touching your body..." Feng Yuxiang said as she kneeled in front of Yuan.

Seeing Feng Yuxiang kneeling right in front of him, Yuan raised his eyebrows, and his heart began beating faster for some reason.

After taking a deep breath, Feng Yuxiang moved her hands towards the stiff rod located directly between Yuan's legs.

Yuan immediately felt a chill go down his back when he felt Feng Yuxiang's soft hands touching his thing.

Feng Yuxiang's body also trembled when her hands touched Yuan's hot rod, feeling it twitching in her hands.

Once she had a good grip on Yuan's rod, Feng Yuxiang began to gently move her hands in a stroking motion.

Yuan was baffled by what Feng Yuxiang was doing to his body, as this was completely new to him.

However, as weird as it looked, it actually felt incredibly pleasurable, so Yuan didn't stop her and allowed Feng Yuxiang to continue.

"H-How does it feel, Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang asked him in a nervous voice a few minutes into their session.

Never could she have imagined that she would one day use her hands to please a man in such a manner— a human, too.

"I don't know... It feels good, but it also hurts a little, mostly when you move your hands down," he gave her his honest feedback.

"It does look a little dry..." Feng Yuxiang mumbled in a low voice.

However, there was no water around her, and she didn't want to leave the room to get some water now that they were in this kind of situation.

After pondering for a moment, Feng Yuxiang decided to use her saliva.

"Young Master, I am going to use my saliva to get rid of the dryness. It'll most likely stop the pain," she then said to him.

"O-Okay..." Yuan nodded despite the weird idea.

Once she had his approval, Feng Yuxiang moved her mouth closer to his rod before spitting some of her saliva onto it.

Once it was soaking wet with her saliva, Feng Yuxiang continued to massage Yuan's rod.

"What about now?" Feng Yuxiang asked him a moment later.

"It feels much better. I don't feel the pain anymore," he said.

"Then I will move a little faster."

Feng Yuxiang started stroking his rod faster.

A few minutes later, Yuan felt an indescribable feeling shock his body.

"I-I need to go to the bathroom!" He quickly said to Feng Yuxiang after realizing what this feeling was.

However, Feng Yuxiang said, "It's okay, Young Master. Just let it out here. I will clean it up later."

"Are you sure?" Yuan was baffled by her answer.

"Yes," she confirmed.

A moment later, Yuan could no longer hold this feeling back and gave up on trying.

The next second—

"Ah!"

Feng Yuxiang shouted in a startled voice when a burst of white substance shot out from Yuan's rod and went straight onto the wall a few meters behind her.

However, it didn't stop after the first shot, and it continued shooting out the white substance, splattering the wall with white stuff all over.

Yuan's body collapsed onto the bed after releasing everything, feeling incredibly exhausted afterward.

Feng Yuxiang looked at her hands that were also stained with Yuan's sticky white stuff with a dazed look on her face.

She then looked at Yuan's rod, and to her surprise, it was still as stiff as a rock.

"Y-Young Master... Looks like we'll have to do this a couple more times before you release all of your excess energy..." Feng Yuxiang said to him.

"Is this really going to help?" Yuan asked her a moment later.

"Yes, but since the treasure you absorbed was quite powerful, it'll take some time before we can fully relieve it."

"Okay. Sorry for the trouble, Feng Feng." Yuan said to her with an innocent look on his face.

Seeing Yuan's innocent expression, Feng Yuxiang felt incredibly guilty for some reason even though she was trying to help him.

Sometime later, Feng Yuxiang continued helping Yuan release his excess energy. As for Yuan, since he recently climaxed, his rod was more sensitive than before, allowing him to feel the pleasure from Feng Yuxiang's hands even more.

Author's Note: I know this novel has been pretty PG-rated up to this point, and this chapter just went up a level. I have yet to decide whether I want to make this novel more mature or keep it PG, so I want some feedback. Let me know your thoughts in the comments. Even if I decide to make this novel more mature, it won't be as mature as 'Dual Cultivation' if you have read it before. Just some flavor here and there to spice the novel up a bit, I guess.

Do you want more mature scenes like this or no? Why and why not?

I know the character development is slow, but Yuan will eventually grow up, and keeping him innocent forever isn't realistic even for a fictional novel. Therefore, let me know your thoughts in the comments. Cheers.

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Chapter 484 – A Secret

"Haaa... haaa..." Yuan laid on the bed while breathing heavily.

"Okay, Young Master. I am done. Your condition has finally been relieved." Feng Yuxiang said to him as she stood up.

After spending a few hours in the bedroom, Feng Yuxiang has managed to extract a week's worth of excess energy from Yuan's body, who'd absorbed too much treasure from his body tempering.

"Thank you, Feng Feng..." Yuan said to her afterward.

"I am merely doing my job as a servant, Young Master. There's no need to thank me, as it was my fault you were in that condition in the first place." Feng Yuxiang said as she used her phoenix flames to clean the sticky white substances in the room without damaging the walls or floor even in the slightest.

"Anyway, you can stay here and rest until you're ready to move again. I will be outside with the others."

"Oh... And can you keep whatever happened in here a secret between us, Young Master?"

"Yes... I don't think I want them to know either..." Yuan agreed.

"Thank you, Young Master. I will see you later."

Despite her calm voice, Feng Yuxiang's face was fully flushed with redness, and her steps were a little unbalanced, looking a little tipsy from drinking too much.

Once Feng Yuxiang left the room, Yuan continued to lay on the bed with a look of wonder on his face.

Today, he has experienced a new world— one that he would forever remember.

Sometime later, when Yu Rou noticed Feng Yuxiang coming out of the room, she quickly approached her and said, "I hope you didn't do anything you weren't supposed to!"

Feng Yuxiang showed a smile on her face and said, "Don't worry, I only did what was necessary to help his condition. I respect the Young Master's body as much as you do, so I wouldn't dare to do whatever you're thinking."

"Anyways, the Young Master's condition has been fixed. I am going to get some fresh air. I probably won't be back for a while."

Feng Yuxiang then left the building and flew away, not returning for a couple of days.

About an hour after Feng Yuxiang left, Yuan emerged from the room with a refreshed look on his face, and even his aura experienced a small change.

"B-Brother... Are you okay now?" Yu Rou asked him with a slightly rosy face, trying her hardest to not look away from him.

"Yes, I am fine now."

"What happened inside?"

To everyone's surprise, Xiao Hua was the one who asked him this question.

Yuan chuckled and said, "That's a secret."

"A secret...?" Everyone there looked at him with wide eyes, their imaginations running wild.

"By the way, where's Feng Feng?" Yuan then noticed that she was missing.

"She went outside for some fresh air, and she also said that she won't be back for a while." Yu Rou said.

"Oh... I see..."

Sometime later, Yu Rou asked, "What should we do now, brother?"

"Whatever you want, I guess."

"Well, I am not sure what I want to do, but I am tired of doing quests," she said.

"Then do you want to just explore the Lower Heavens?"

"What do you mean by exploring? Do we just walk around?"

Yuan nodded, "Yes. We don't need to do anything special, just travel around the world like we're going on a massive trip."

"I want to see as much of the Lower Heavens as I can before I move up to the next realm."

"A journey around the world, huh? That does sound like a good idea." Yu Rou nodded.

"What about you, Jingyi? You don't have to follow us if you don't want to."

"I don't mind following along. Besides, I don't really have anyone else to play with, and I also enjoy being with you guys," she said.

"Okay! Then it's decided! Let's go on a journey! Do you have any destination in mind?" Yu Rou then said to Yuan.

"Not really. I was going to ask Feng Feng to see if there were any cool places we could go in the Lower Heavens. What about you, Xiao Hua? Do you know of any places like that?"

Xiao Hua shook her head.

"I can look online and see if there are any places like that," Yu Rou suddenly said.

"Okay. Let's also wait for Feng Feng to return before we leave." Yuan said.

They proceeded to walk around the city until it was late and had to log off for dinner.

After dinner, Meixiu asked, "Yuan, do you want a shower tonight? You released a lot of sweat today."

"Okay," he said.

Meixiu then carried Yuan into the bathroom with the wheelchair, and just as Meixiu prepared to remove her clothes so it doesn't get wet, she remembered that Yuan could see again with his divine sense, so she restrained from going inside the bathroom naked like she normally would.

After rinsing his body with some warm water, Meixiu began scrubbing his body with her soapy hands.

When she reached his lower area, Meixiu paused her movements momentarily after recalling what happened today.

A moment later, she started cleaning Yuan's cute thing that was a contrast to what she saw earlier today.

When Yuan felt Meixiu's soft hands touching this area, Yuan couldn't help but remember what Feng Yuxiang did to him, and his body naturally reacted with an erection.

Meixiu swallowed nervously when she saw this, and she tried her best to clean it with a clear mind.

However, Yuan suddenly asked her, "Meixiu... I thought my body only reacted like this because of the treasure, so why is it like this now? Did the treasures from the game affect my real body too?"

"Uhh..."

Meixiu was left speechless by Yuan's innocent question and wasn't sure how she should respond to him.

'Should I just tell him...?'

As much as she wanted to avoid this topic, Meixiu knew that it was impossible and that he would have to learn about it eventually, and keeping such important knowledge from him would only hurt him in the long run, especially since his body is recovering.

Therefore, Meixiu has decided to teach Yuan what it means to be a man and why his body reacts the way it does.

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Chapter 485 – What It Means To Be A Man

Meixiu closed her eyes and took a couple of deep breaths before opening them with a resolute expression on her beautiful face.

"Yuan, I know none of this is your fault because of how the Yu Family raised you, but you're too innocent and ignorant for someone your age. You're already 18— an adult. You cannot continue living like this, especially since you'll eventually recover from your condition." Meixiu said to him in a sighing voice.

"W-What do you mean?" Yuan asked her in a nervous voice.

"You have been playing instruments since the day you entered the Yu Family, and that is all the Yu Family has ever taught you, ignoring your common sense and other important knowledge. You were also crippled at a very young age, even going into isolation, which limited your knowledge even further."

"I am trying to say that you're missing a lot of common sense."

"..."

After a moment of silence, Yuan spoke in a low voice, "Then what am I supposed to do?"

Meixiu then said, "You don't have to do anything, Yuan, because I will help you. I will give you the knowledge that the Yu Family didn't care to give you— what it means to be a man."

Meixiu then looked at his stiff rod and continued, "Let's start with this..."

Yuan's body trembled slightly when Meixiu suddenly touched his stiff area, but the way Meixiu held it felt a little different than usual.

"The condition you're in right now is called an 'erection'. It happens when your body is stimulated with excitement, and most of the time, it is sexual excitement that causes it to react in such a way."

"S-Sexual excitement? What is that?" Yuan asked, as he never really had the chance to experience it for himself because he would only focus on music almost all of the time.

Furthermore, besides Meixiu, Yu Rou, and the servants working in the Yu Family, Yuan barely had any contact with females.

"Sexual excitement is when you feel aroused," Meixiu explained to him.

"It's a natural feeling of desire you get for the opposite gender when you're interested in them— or whoever you want to embrace."

"I don't understand that feeling..." Yuan sighed.

"It's okay. You don't have to understand it now. You just need to be aware of it." Meixiu said.

And she continued, "Now, whenever one feels aroused, their body will react a certain way, and when it comes to men, the thing between their legs will react the way your body is currently reacting. Of course, there are other situations that could make your body react in such a manner, but most of the time, it's arousal."

"I see... Is that why my body is acting like this? Because I am aroused?" Yuan asked in an innocent and calm voice.

"Well... Only you can really tell..." Meixiu said.

Yuan then said, "When you touched that area, my mind would remember what Feng Feng did to me to help me relieve it, and my body started to feel warmer."

"What Feng Feng did to you...?" Meixiu raised her eyebrows.

"Well, I cannot give you any details since I promised Feng Feng that I'd keep it a secret, but she used her hands like you..." Yuan said in a slightly embarrassed voice.

"I see..." Meixiu could imagine what had happened between Feng Yuxiang and Yuan after he just said.

"Although you may not understand the feeling of arousal, your body can be naturally aroused even if you don't know it yourself, and that is most likely what is happening now."

"Then how can I get rid of this feeling?" Yuan asked.

"That feeling will naturally go away if you stop thinking about it," Meixiu said.

"The reason it didn't go away before was because of a medicine that affected your body, so it wouldn't calm down until you use the other method to calm it down."

"That method..." Yuan mumbled.

"Yes, it's most likely what Feng Feng did to help you."

Yuan swallowed nervously, and he asked, "Does it matter which method one uses?"

"..."

After a slight pause, Meixiu said, "Yes, it does."

"Although one can ignore their arousal and let it calm down naturally, that feeling doesn't actually go away very effectively and will eventually build up. And as it continues to build up, it could affect one's mind negatively and make them do things they normally wouldn't do, which is also called sexual frustration, so one should use the second method to relieve themselves once in a while."

Meixiu then looked at Yuan's rod that was in her grasp, and she continued, "Now that you have learned about arousal, you'll most likely be experiencing them more often."

"What? Is that how it works?"

"Yes, it is. Especially since you're at that age..."

"I see... Then what should I do? If I cannot keep ignoring it, I will have to relieve myself, right? That will be difficult in my condition." Yuan sighed.

Meixiu took a deep breath before speaking, "Don't worry, Yuan. I will do it for you."

"Eh? Really? Are you sure? Feng Feng acted weird afterward when she did it for me so I thought she didn't like it. I don't want you to do something you don't like..."

"Feng Feng acted weird not because she didn't like it; it was because she was embarrassed. Normally, a woman won't willingly do something like that if she didn't like the person, and nobody forced her, so she definitely didn't mind it." Meixiu said.

'Furthermore, I was trained to relieve you if you ever needed it...' Meixiu said inwardly, as she didn't dare to tell him out loud.

"I see... It's relieving to know that she didn't hate it..." Yuan released a sigh of relief.

Seeing Yuan's good-natured character, Meixiu felt something weird in her heart.

"Then let me relieve you now. You have been naked long enough. If we stay like this any further, you might catch a cold."

As she finished her sentence, Meixiu began moving her hands, stroking Yuan's stiff rod more skillfully than when Feng Yuxiang experienced it with her hands.

'This is my first time doing this on a real person...' Meixiu thought to herself as she pleased Yuan's sword with her hands.

When her mother trained her to take care of Yuan's every need, it was only on toys and mannequins, so this was her actual first experience.

A few moments into their session, Yuan's body could already feel the difference between Meixiu and Feng Yuxiang's hand techniques, and that difference was quite vast, almost like heaven and hell.

When Feng Yuxiang stroked it, it was much more forceful and fast, and she would sometimes grip onto it with too much strength. However, when Meixiu strokes it, he could feel the tenderness in her slow and gentle movements, almost like she was treating his thing like a treasure, and it was a constant feeling.

Furthermore, Meixiu would use her other hand to massage other areas while her main hand was busy relieving his sword, enhancing the effects of her already skillful techniques.

Yuan's body reached its limit in just three short minutes under Meixiu's skillful hand techniques.

Feeling the rod in her hands twitching, Meixiu said in a soothing voice, "Go ahead. Let it out and relieve yourself."

Hearing her voice, Yuan removed the blockade and released a stream of white substance from his lower body.

And right before Yuan released his stress, Meixiu placed her other hand a few inches away from his rod so that his release wouldn't go everywhere in the bathroom.

Meixiu could feel something warm and powerful shoot into her hands the next moment, and it would continue shooting into her palms for a couple more times before it stopped.

"How are you feeling?" Meixiu asked him afterward.

"Like something was relieved from my body... Thank you..." Yuan said to her.

Meixiu then washed away the white stuff on her hand and the floor with the showerhead.

Once that was done, she proceeded to rinse the soap from Yuan's body.

A few minutes later, she carried Yuan back to his room and dried his body with towels.

"Let me take a shower before we continue our talk, okay?" Meixiu then said to him.

"Okay."

Meixiu then returned to the bathroom to take a shower, taking much longer than she normally would for some reason.

Once she was eventually done, Meixiu returned to Yuan's room and continued to educate him about things that the Yu Family never taught him.

Chapter 486 An Unexpected Find

"Thank you, Meixiu, for the lesson. I will keep in mind everything you have taught me today." Yuan said to her after spending an hour getting lectured about the differences between men and women.

"Then I will go back to my room now. I am more exhausted than usual for some reason," Meixiu said to him.

"Okay. Good night." Yuan said to her.

Once she returned to her room, Meixiu buried her face into the pillow and proceeded to suffocate herself until she could no longer endure it.

However, she was unable to calm down despite doing that.

'I have done it... I really did that to him...' Meixiu cried inwardly, recalling what she'd done to Yuan inside the bathroom.

Although she'd expected to do such things and even more before for Yuan when she was being trained by her mother, that was years ago, and they were no longer in the Yu Family. Furthermore, their relationship has evolved to being much more than just a servant and master.

Meixiu would proceed to spend the entire night thinking about how she should act when around Yuan.

As for Yuan... He slept like a baby, instantly falling asleep a few seconds after closing his eyes, and if one went into his room while he slept, one would see a gentle smile on his face.

Meanwhile, around the same time at the Yu Family, a middle-aged man wearing a black suit stood before Yu Yong and Tang Lee.

"Master Yu, Madam Tang, we have located her location." This middle-aged man said.

"Thank you, Mister Johnson. Where is Meixiu right now?" Yu Yong then asked this middle-aged man, who he'd hired to investigate Meixiu's whereabouts.

"After looking through some of the surveillance cameras in the streets, we have managed to locate the building Meixiu lives in, and it's an apartment about an hour away from this place."

"During our investigation on Meixiu, we also found something unexpected — that she appears to be with Yu Tian."

"What? Meixiu is with that useless thing? Are you sure? Why didn't the Chairman tell us that when he visited?" Tang Lee exclaimed in a surprised voice.

Mister Johnson nodded and said, "We saw them entering the apartment together, and after speaking with Chairman Zhao, he confirmed that there was a cripple in a wheelchair with Meixiu at the Cultivators' Association."

"We even have a picture from the surveillance."

Mister Johnson proceeded to show them a picture of Meixiu pushing a wheelchair that carried Yuan.

Yu Yong frowned and said, "She left the Yu Family to be with him? Why am I not surprised? She was trained by Meifeng to be his personal maid at one point."

"Of course there's someone with him. That trash can't possibly live by himself now that Yu Rou is no longer helping him. However, does this also mean that Meifeng had lied to us about Meixiu's situation? I refuse to believe that she didn't know about her daughter's situation." Tang Lee then said.

Yu Yong raised his eyebrows and said, "Meifeng has remained loyal to the family ever since she joined the family. I don't believe that she would lie to us. Though we should still talk to her about this just in case."

"Anyway, this is an entirely different situation that can be dealt with after our current one. Can you bring Meixiu back to us, Mister Johnson?" Yu Yong asked the middle-aged man.

He nodded and said, "Although we have located her whereabouts, we have yet to locate her exact location. We know where she lives, but we don't know where exactly, and the building owners refused to give us access to the surveillance cameras without a proper reason."

"What are you trying to say? It's just an apartment. Go knock on every single door until you find her. That's why we hired you." Tang Lee said with a frown.

Mister Johnson smiled and said, "Madam Tang, we were only paid to locate her whereabouts, and that is exactly what we have done. The contract doesn't state that we have to do anything else once we find her location."

The frown on Tang Lee's face grew deeper, but before she could speak, Mister Johnson continued, "In case you forgot, Meixiu was called a cultivation genius by Chairman Zhao himself. If that's the case, there's a good chance that she's a high-level cultivator at this moment. Even if we knock on every door and find her, we cannot physically force her to come with us if she refuses since our team doesn't have the manpower to do so."

"If there's a chance that we must use force to bring Meixiu back to the Yu Family, we will need to hire more people— cultivators that are powerful enough to bring her back. However, powerful cultivators are not easy to find. Do you understand where I am getting at?"

Yu Yong pondered for a moment before speaking, "In other words, you are asking us for more money. Is that correct?"

Mister Johnson merely smiled at his question, his answer clear.

"I don't care how much it will cost. I want her back at the Yu Family. We can simply have Chairman Zhao cover the cost of the operation and more when we give him Meixiu." Tang Lee said in a cold voice.

"Very well. I will immediately assemble a team of powerful cultivators to bring Meixiu back. It should be done by the end of the week." Mister Johnson said.

"As for the price, we will calculate everything once we get the team together before sending them to you. Once we receive the payment, we will immediately bring her back."

Mister Johnson said, implying that unless they receive the money, they wouldn't do anything. Although the Yu Family is a powerful family, they were not completely invincible and almighty in this world, so not everyone will be willing to work for them without money, which is the real power.

After Mister Johnson left the place, Yu Yong summoned Meifeng to their home despite it being incredibly late at night.

Meifeng, who was asleep at the time, had to wake up and make her way to their place after being called, but she didn't complain, as she puts her masters' needs before her own needs.

Half an hour later, Meifeng arrived at the Yu Family.

Chapter 487 Questioning Meifeng

"Meifeng, have you found Meixiu's whereabouts yet?" Yu Yong asked her the moment she arrived at the house, acting as though he didn't have a single clue.

"Unfortunately, I have not." Meifeng said, and she continued, "I tried calling her every day, but she hasn't responded to a single call."

"Are you sure you don't know?" Tang Lee asked again, narrowing her eyes.

"I don't understand. Are you implying that I know her whereabouts? That I am lying to you?" Meifeng then asked, feeling something was off about their atmosphere.

Yu Yong then retrieved a photo and placed it on the table, showing a picture of Meixiu and Yuan on the street.

It was the same photo given to them by Mister Johnson.

"Your daughter is currently taking care of that trash, and she left the family shortly after he was disowned. This doesn't seem like a coincidence, and I refuse to believe that you, her mother, didn't know about this." Tang Lee said.

And she continued, "You know what I think? I think you knew about her whereabouts this entire time and purposefully kept it from us. In fact, you probably even helped them."

"..."

Meifeng remained silent after hearing Tang Lee doubt her loyalty, even suspecting that she had something to do with Meixiu's disappearance.

However, she didn't panic.

"With all due respect, Madam Tang, I have worked for the Yu Family for nearly my entire life, and I had sacrificed everything in order to do so. Why would I risk all of that over something like this?"

"The last time I spoke with Meixiu was right before she left. She told me that she wanted to leave the Yu Family to explore other options in life. Meixiu isn't bound to a contract, nor did I have any reason to convince her to stay since she's already an adult, so I didn't say anything and allowed her to leave." Meifeng said, subtly reminding them that Meixiu wasn't under a contract so they cannot force her to stay.

Meifeng then continued without giving the Yu Family a chance to speak, "Allow me to be blunt, Masters."

"Meixiu has admired the Young Master ever since he was adopted into the family, and she'd even endured countless hours of training from me just to become his servant. However, because of what happened to the Young Master, she was reassigned to the Young Lady. I am not saying that she doesn't care about the Young Lady, but she has always dreamed of being the Young Master's servant."

"Since the Young Master got removed from the family, Meixiu, who is not bound by a contract, most likely decided to leave the family so that she could finally fulfill her dream as the Young Master's servant. Of course, this is all speculation, but other than logical reasoning, I am also her mother, so I know what she thinks."

Yu Yong and Tang Lee were left speechless by Meifeng's words.

After a moment of silence, Yu Yong said, "I don't doubt you, Meifeng, but just to be safe, let me see your cellphone. Since you claim that you call her every day, you must have a record of it in your phone."

The Yu Family expected Meifeng to make an excuse to get out of this situation, but to their surprise, Meifeng said, "I understand."

She then retrieved her cellphone and handed it over to Yu Yong without making any excuses or showing even the slightest sign of being worried.

Yu Yong then opened her phone and checked the call record.

His eyes widened with surprise when he saw that Meifeng had actually been calling Meixiu's phone number every single day without fail ever since Meixiu left the family, and she would sometimes even call Meixiu multiple times in one day.

However, there was not a single successful call within the call records.

"I-I apologize for doubting you, Meifeng... Really... If we'd offended you, please forgive us." Yu Yong immediately apologized to her.

Yu Yong valued Meifeng's loyalty and presence in the Yu Family very highly— probably only second to his own wife.

This is mostly because of Meifeng's contribution to the Yu Family throughout the years. It could be said that without Meifeng assisting them, their family wouldn't have survived for this long.

While Yuan have boosted their wealth to a significant amount, they have always been rich. However, Meifeng had helped them stabilize their position within the entertainment industry and much more, hence why Yu Yong couldn't afford to anger or offend Meifeng.

Even though Meifeng was under a contract with their Yu Family, she could actually leave the family if she truly tried, and Yu Yong couldn't afford to lose someone like her, especially not when the entire world was changing at a rapid pace because of the cultivation craze.

"I am neither mad nor offended, just slightly disappointed that I don't have all of your trust just yet," Meifeng said.

"D-Don't worry! You have my complete trust starting now!" Yu Yong reassured her.

However, Tang Lee wasn't happy with the results, and she was still suspicious of Meifeng, but she didn't say anything and merely kept a frown on her face.

Meifeng then asked, "If you don't mind me asking, why are you so fixated on finding Meixiu?"

Yu Yong sighed and decided to tell Meifeng everything.

"To tell you the truth, we're not really the ones who are looking for her—it's Chairman Zhao, the current chairman of the Cultivators' Association. Apparently, Meixiu has incredible talents in cultivation, which attracted Chairman Zhao's attention, and he wants to buy Meixiu from us."

"What?" Meifeng's eyes widened upon learning the truth, showing a little surprise for the first time.

"Therefore, we have hired investigators to look for her. They have recently found her whereabouts, and they are planning on bringing Meixiu back soon."

"What about Meixiu? What if she doesn't want to join the Cultivators' Association?" Meifeng asked.

"Meifeng, you should know by now that if someone is powerful enough, they can do whatever they want. Chairman Zhao is definitely someone powerful enough to do as he pleases. If he truly wants Meixiu, there's nothing you nor the Yu Family can do about it." Yu Yong sighed again.

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Author's Note: There is a new voting system for FreeWebNovel called Golden Tickets for the premium novels that will reset once a month. You can get them through spending coins or gifting the novel a certain amount(500+). If you don't have this in your app, update the app.

Therefore, in order to bribe you into voting, I shall give you THREE bonus chapters(including daily chapters) for both Dual Cultivation and Cultivation

Online if Hero's Carnage, my new novel, reaches 1,000 Golden Tickets.

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Chapter 488 Don't Underestimate Him

Sometime after listening to the whole story from Yu Yong, Meifeng prepared to return home.

"Meifeng, I know she is your daughter, but there's nothing we can do. I guess we can only be happy for Meixiu that she'd caught the attention of someone prestigious like Chairman Zhao. If she's with him and the Cultivators' Association, I am sure that she will live a fulfilling life. And I apologize again for calling you here so late in the middle of the night. You can take tomorrow off if you'd like." Yu Yong said to her before she left.

Once she was in her car, Meifeng drove straight home while pondering the whole way there.

'The Chairman of the Cultivators' Association... He's definitely not someone the Yu Family can deal with, much less Meixiu... This is troublesome...'

After returning home, Meifeng went straight to the locked drawer beside her bed.

She then opened it and retrieved a burner phone and opened it.

A moment later, she dialed a number.

"Hello?" Meixiu answered the phone call quicker than Meifeng had expected since it was way past midnight.

"Why are you up so late at night?" Meifeng asked her.

"I can ask you the same... Why are you calling me so late at night, mother?"

"You've gotten a lot more courageous since you left the Yu Family— to the point where you even dare to talk back to me," Meifeng said.

"Anyways, let me get straight to the topic. Are you aware how much trouble you're in right now?"

"Trouble? What are you talking about?" Meixiu's puzzled voice resounded.

"Do you remember when I told you that Chairman Zhao from the Cultivators' Association had contacted the Yu Family? Well, the Yu Family has hired investigators to find out your whereabouts, and they have learned about the apartment. However, that's not even the worst part. They know about the Young Master as well."

"What!" Meixiu exclaimed in a surprised voice.

The Yu Family went out of their way to hire investigators to look for her? Just how desperate are they trying to recruit her to the Cultivators' Association?

"Even if they know about our location... Does it really matter? I am no longer with the Yu Family, nor do I want to join the Cultivators' Association. It's not like they can force me either." Meixiu said.

Meifeng sighed, "You are underestimating the world of adults and how influential some people are, Meixiu. There are some people out there who are so powerful that you have no choice but to agree."

"As for the Yu Family, they will make you return to the family whether you like it or not, and they will sell you to the Cultivators' Association. In fact, the investigators are already preparing a team of cultivators to force you to return to the family."

"What! What should I do? I cannot leave Yua— Yu Tian's side now!" Meixiu said.

"You can move out of that apartment before they get you, but that will only delay them since they will eventually find you again, and it won't be easy moving in the street without being seen when you have to travel with the Young Master in his condition. Therefore, you can only confront this matter from the front."

"What are you trying to say?" Meixiu asked.

"Do you remember what I taught you? What you should do if there are people who threaten the Young Master's safety?" Meifeng asked her.

"...I can't forget it even if I want to..." Meixiu mumbled in a low voice.

"Good, and since you're a cultivator, you should be even more powerful. Just make sure you don't kill them and you should be fine. Ah, make sure you report it to the police afterward just in case."

"I won't be contacting you again for a while since the Yu Family is suspecting that I'd helped with your disappearance. Once you have dealt with the problem, call me on my burner only after midnight."

"I understand."

"Make sure you keep the Young Master safe since there's a good chance that they might use the Young Master to force you to return."

A slight smile appeared on Meixiu's face when she recalled Yuan's flying dagger technique and said, "Don't underestimate him, mother. He may not be able to move properly, but I doubt there's anyone more powerful than him right now."

Meifeng was left speechless for once by Meixiu.

"What do you mean by that?" She couldn't help but ask.

"You'll find out eventually, mother. Anyway, I am going to get some sleep. You should too. Goodnight." Meixiu closed the connection before Meifeng could even respond.

"This little girl definitely got more courageous, even a little cheeky... Something must have happened..." Meifeng mumbled to herself before lying on her bed and falling asleep.

Meanwhile, Meixiu laid on the bed and stared at the ceiling with a dazed look on her face.

"I just want a peaceful life with him... Why is everyone making things so complicated?" She sighed in a low voice.

After a moment of silence, she muttered in a cold voice, "I won't let anyone take him away from me now... no matter who they are..."

Meixiu then fell asleep for two short hours before waking up to prepare breakfast.

"Good morning, Meixiu... Hmm? You look tired. Did you not get enough sleep yesterday?" Yuan greeted her while using his Divine Sense.

"Yuan, I have some bad news," she said.

"What happened?"

Meixiu sighed and said, "It's the Yu Family. They hired investigators to find me, and they now know about our location... Including the fact that you're with me."

Yuan remained silent for a moment before speaking, "Even if they know about our location, what are they going to do about it? Force you to go back?"

Meixiu nodded, "From what my mother told me when she called me last night... Yes..."

"What? How is that even legal?" Yuan exclaimed.

"Well, it's not, but when you're powerful and influential like the Yu Family and the fact that they're supported by the Chairman of the Cultivators'

Association... There's really pretty much nothing they cannot get away with as long as it isn't mass murder..." Meixiu sighed.

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Chapter 489 More Kitchen Knives

"That's unfair! If they don't need to follow the rules because they are powerful, then this is no different than the cultivation world!"

"Well... If you really think about it, the cultivation world and this world are pretty similar in some aspects, especially if you're rich and powerful." Meixiu said.

Yuan sighed.

"What should we do then? Move?" He asked a moment later.

"I asked the same, but my mother said there's no point since they will find us again sooner or later."

"Miss Meifeng? Then what did she suggest?"

"She told us to confront them."

"Confront them? How?"

"By chasing them away, I guess."

"What? She wants us to chase them away? Is that even possible?"

"I will try."

"Don't tell me you're going to fight them?"

"..."

After a moment of silence, Meixiu said, "If it gets to that point, but you don't have to worry about me because I can protect myself just fine. I am more worried about you since you are vulnerable in that condition."

"Even if you say that..."

"Anyway, even if they are targeting me, it is my job to take care of you, and I won't be able to do that if they take me away from you."

Yuan sighed.

"Looks like we won't be able to play with Yu Rou and the others until this is all over. I will have to apologize to her later," he said a moment later.

"I will stay out here just in case they knock on the door."

"Okay."

After breakfast, Yuan entered Cultivation Online.

"Morning, brother. Where's Meixiu?" Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi greeted him.

"She won't be on today... Actually, we won't be able to play for the next few days."

"What? Why? Did something happen?" Yu Rou frowned.

Yuan nodded and said, "The Yu Family hired investigators to find us, and they are now planning on forcing Meixiu back so that she could join the Cultivators' Association."

Yuan explained the situation to them.

"What! They're still on that?! Unbelievable! How can they treat Meixiu like that?! I am going to speak with my parents later!" Yu Rou exclaimed in an angry voice.

Xia Jingyi was shocked. This was her first time hearing about their situation, too.

"Do you want me to talk to my parents about this? We can probably do something about them entering the apartment." Xia Jingyi said.

Yuan shook his head and said, "It's okay, I am sure we will be fine, and I don't want to drag your family into our trouble."

"Okay, but give me a call if you ever change your mind."

"Brother Tian, what is this Cultivators' Association?" Xiao Hua asked him.

"It's a complicated situation... I don't think I can even explain it." Yuan said to her.

"Don't worry, I will be back in a few days hopefully. Until then, you guys can play without us."

"I don't think we can play in peace knowing that you're in trouble..." Yu Rou sighed.

"Stay safe. I will still let my parents know so that they can keep watch, but they won't intervene unless absolutely necessary." Xia Jingyi said.

"Thank you." Yuan nodded.

"What are you going to do in the meantime?" Yu Rou then asked.

"Well, we're going to see what they're going to actually do. Until then, I really cannot say."

"Okay. Keep us updated." Yu Rou said.

Sometime later, Yuan logged off the game.

Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi also logged off shortly after since they were no longer in the mood to play.

"I have told Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi about their situation," Yuan said to Meixiu afterward.

"Now we just wait, huh?" Meixiu sighed.

"I am going to practice the Flying Daggers since that is the only way I can help you in case you're in trouble." Yuan then said.

"Flying Daggers? You'll kill them." Meixiu chuckled.

"..."

Yuan remained silent, his thoughts unknown.

"Anyways, I am going to cultivate too. Hopefully, I will be able to break into Spirit Warrior before they find us." Meixiu said before returning to her room.

Once Meixiu left, Yuan mumbled in a low voice, "If I have to protect you..."

Sometime later, Yuan cleared his mind and began practicing Flying Daggers, making incredible progress in just a single day.

Whoosh!

A kitchen knife flew around the room like a paper airplane, but unlike a paper airplane that could not be controlled, Yuan could control the direction and speed of the kitchen knife with precision.

Once he was confident with controlling a single kitchen knife, Yuan wondered if he could control two of them at once.

Although he has only ever tried to control one dagger at a time even in Cultivation Online, that was only because he only had the Starry Abyss, and that was the only dagger he really ever needed.

"Meixiu! Sorry to disturb your cultivation, but can you bring in a few more kitchen knives?" Yuan called out to her.

A minute later, Meixiu came into the room with two more kitchen knives in her hands, and she asked him, "Why do you need so many knives?"

"I want to see if I can control more than one at a time," he said.

"More than one...? Well, just don't overboard and hurt yourself..." Meixiu said as she placed the knives on the chair.

Once Meixiu left the room, Yuan immediately began trying to control two knives at once.\

And to his surprise, he was able to lift two knives at once.

However, he quickly learned that while he could levitate two knives at once, controlling them simultaneously was an entirely separate story.

"This is much more difficult than I'd expected..." Yuan sighed out loud as he proceeded to spend the rest of the day trying to control two knives at once.

The following day, Yuan continued to practice his Flying Daggers while attempting to breakthrough to Spirit Master.

Time passed quickly, and before they were aware, almost a week had passed.

Meanwhile, somewhere in the city, Mister Johnson stood before four individuals emitting profound auras, all of them with cultivation at the seventh level with one even at the eighth level.

Chapter 490 Going From Door to Door

"Our target this time is a genius cultivator named Meixiu. This is what she looks like." Mister Johnson showed them a picture of Meixiu.

One of the cultivators immediately whistled, "Whoa, what a beauty."

"She's not only beautiful, she's also a cultivation genius. Don't underestimate her, or you might regret it." Mister Johnson said.

And he continued, "According to the Cultivators' Association, Meixiu claimed to be at the ninth level of Spirit Apprentice. If this is true, she has one of if not the highest cultivation in the city."

"Ninth level? No wonder why you called four of us to kidnap a single girl. However, even if she has a high cultivation base, it won't matter if she doesn't know how to utilize it properly. I highly doubt she'll cause any trouble for us, or are you underestimating us, huh?"

"Scorpion is right, Johnson. So what if she's at the ninth level? She's still within Spirit Apprentice. The difference between each level as a Spirit Apprentice isn't that vast. Even if we have a lower cultivation base, our combat experience will make up for it," said another person there.

"She's just a little girl. I doubt we'll face any troubles when dealing with her. In fact, I can even take her by myself."

Hearing their confident voice, Mister Johnson said, "Since you're all so confident, I won't bother going into the details. Just bear in mind that you're not allowed to hurt her too badly. The Chairman of the Cultivators'

Association has a great interest in this girl. If you hurt her— or even worse, damage her cultivation talents, you'll have to bear responsibility."

"What? The Chairman of the Cultivators' Association is also in on this? Just what is so special about this girl beside her cultivation talents?" One of them asked.

"Our job isn't to ask questions. Just do whatever you are being paid to do." Mister Johnson said.

He then placed a map on the table and pointed at the clear red dot on the map.

"This is her whereabouts, but it's an apartment, and we don't know which room she is living in exactly, so we'll have to knock on every single door until we find her."

"What a pain in the ass... But we're getting good money for such an easy job so I won't complain... too much."

"When do we carry out this mission?"

"As soon as possible," said Mister Johnson.

"Alright. We'll start right now."

Sometime later, the four hired cultivators left the briefing room and made their way to their destination.

Once they arrived, they changed their clothes, wearing uniforms meant for carriers, disguising themselves as someone who makes deliveries.

"There are 27 floors in this apartment, and it will take forever if we go through it one floor at a time, so let's split up into a group of two. One group will check the even-numbered floors while the other group searches the odd-numbered floors. If we find Meixiu, immediately contact the other group."

The other three nodded.

"According to Johnson, Meixiu is living with only one other person— a cripple, so she should be the only one answering the door."

Once they decided on their groups, they entered the apartment and started knocking on doors.

"Hello! You have a delivery!"

"I don't remember buying anything online..." Some old lady answered the door a moment later.

"Oh, I'm sorry. I must have made a mistake."

When someone that wasn't Meixiu answered the door, they would move onto the next door.

If someone doesn't answer the door, they would note it down so that they could try again later.

The four cultivators proceeded to knock on doors for the entire morning.

First floor... Second floor... Third floor...

Ninth floor... tenth floor...

Thirteenth floor... the fourteenth floor...

Meanwhile, inside 17F on the 17th floor, Meixiu silently absorbed the spiritual energy inside her room.

For the past week, she has done nothing but improve her cultivation base.

As for Yuan, he would continue practicing his Flying Daggers technique.

Suddenly, somebody knocked on the door, but it was not their door— it was the door closest to the elevator.

"Hello! Delivery!"

Hearing this noise, Meixiu opened her eyes and stopped cultivating.

She then stood up and walked to Yuan's room and said to him in a low voice, "They're here."

"What now?"

"Let's just pretend we're not here for as long as possible."

"Okay."

Thus, they ignored the banging on the doors and the man shouting delivery.

The knocking on the door continued for another minute until it stopped.

However, the knocking returned a few moments later, but it was still not their door.

This continued until the knocking eventually reached their door.

"Hello! Delivery!"

"..."

A minute later, the knocking stopped.

Once all of the doors on their floor had been knocked on, the cultivators went to the next floor.

At the end of the day, the four cultivators returned to the car.

"No luck, huh?"

"What now?"

"Well, we have narrowed down the rooms. We will revisit the doors that didn't answer today again tomorrow, and we will continue this until we narrow the choices enough. Once there are less than 10 rooms, we will force our way into these rooms and see for ourselves."

"Sounds good."

They left the apartment shortly after and wouldn't return until the following day.

The next day, they returned to the apartment and started knocking on doors again, but they only visited those that didn't answer them yesterday.

By the end of the day, they narrowed the choices by half.

"Only 21 left now."

They lowered that number to 15 the next day, then 11, and finally down to 7 on the fourth day.

"Meixiu must be in one of these seven rooms. There is one room on the 7th floor, one on the 9th floor, two on the 17th floor, one on the 21st floor, and the last two on the 25th floor. Let's work our way up tomorrow and get it done by the end of the day."

"Understood."

Chapter 491 Midnight Invasion

"Hey, what the hell is taking so long? We're already past our deadline." Mister Johnson called the four cultivators on their fourth day on the job.

"Calm down, Johnson. We'll get the job done by tomorrow. It took longer than expected just knocking on the doors. That bitch Meixiu is definitely avoiding us on purpose. Maybe she is somehow aware that we're looking for her."

"What? How is that possible? Unless someone warned her about us, it's impossible that she's aware of our operation," said Mister Johnson.

"She probably can't hear your knocking because she's playing Cultivation Online."

"If that's the case, it'll make things even more convenient and a breeze when we take her."

"Whatever. Just get it done by tomorrow or your check will see some deductions." Mister Johnson said.

"What! Not our pay!"

"Then hurry up and get the job done before the Yu Family complains even more!" Mister Johnson yelled at them before closing the line.

"You heard him. We better finish tomorrow or our salary will suffer."

"If that's the case, why don't we do it tonight? It'll be much easier to kidnap someone at night."

"You're right... Let's just finish it tonight."

Once everyone agreed on finishing the job tonight, they went to prepare for it.

A few hours later when the sky had turned pitch black, the four cultivators returned to the apartment with a lockpicking kit and started breaking into the rooms that didn't answer them for the past four days, starting with the room on the 7th floor.

Click.

Once they unlocked the door, they silently made their way into the room and began looking around.

Inside the apartment, they could see two people laying on their beds with the Cultivation Online gaming console on their heads.

Seeing this, they approached them to take a look at their faces.

Once they confirmed that neither of them was Meixiu, they silently left the place, leaving the two people completely unaware that they'd just experienced a breaking and entering.

Next was the 9th floor, and just like the previous apartment, everyone living inside was fully immersed within Cultivation Online, completely unaware that they had four intruders inside their home right now.

After leaving the 9th floor, they made their way to the 17th floor and immediately began working on the door that was closest to the elevator.

Luckily for Yuan and Meixiu, their door was the furthest away from the elevator.

Inside the first room on the 17th floor, they could see a family of four currently sleeping.

The moment the cultivators saw four people, they turned around and left the room, as they were only expecting two people at most.

Once they left that room, they began working on the second door on the 17th floor.

"..."

Meixiu, who had been cultivating in her room, suddenly opened her eyes when she could hear subtle noises coming from the door.

'They're breaking in?' Meixiu quickly realized what was going on and immediately stopped cultivating.

She then took a deep breath and silently left her room to wait for them to enter their house without notifying Yuan about the invasion, as there was a good chance that they'd break into their home before she could warn him, and it would be smarter to keep the noises to a minimum.

Click.

The lock to their door suddenly became unlocked, and the door slowly began opening the next moment.

Meixiu could see a shadowy figure enter the house a few seconds later.

However, before he could take two steps inside their peaceful sanctuary, Meixiu, who had been hiding right beside the door suddenly threw a quick but powerful jab at the unsuspecting invader's lower jaw.

Crack.

The sound of bones cracking resounded, startling the other three.

They quickly realized what was going on when the man that entered the room first suddenly fell onto the floor with his neck bent in a weird way.

"Shit! Scorpion is down!"

"I-Is he even still alive?!"

The other three immediately got into position and prepared themselves.

"Show yourself, Meixiu! We're here to bring you back to the Yu Family! Let's not make things difficult!" One of them said to her from outside their home.

Meixiu appeared before them a moment later with the moonlight shining on her beautiful figure, and on her face was a cold expression that complimented the atmosphere quite well.

"I won't go back to the Yu Family. If you want me to go back, you'll have to force me."

"We don't want to hurt you! If you agree to follow us quietly, we will promise to leave that cripple inside alone!"

Meixiu frowned when they pulled Yuan into the topic, even threatening her with him.

"You may have taken out one of us by surprise, but now that you've lost your advantage, you won't be able to take on the three of us by yourself! All of us have over ten years of experience in the military while you're just some little girl with slightly higher cultivation than us! Give up and you won't get hurt!"

"I don't like to repeat myself. If you want me to return to the Yu Family, you will have to force me." Meixiu said.

"Then don't blame us if you get hurt! Get her!"

The man in the front immediately stepped forward to try and grab Meixiu while the other two followed behind, but since the door only had enough room for one person to enter at a time, Meixiu didn't have to worry about fighting all three at once.

She casually took a step back, forcing them to enter the door one by one.

Once the first person entered the apartment, Meixiu immediately propelled herself forward so that the person could not move forward, blocking the other two from entering.

"You're overestimating yourself!" The man went to grab Meixiu again, even utilizing a grappling technique he'd learned from the military.

However, to the man's surprise, Meixiu avoided his grappling technique perfectly, almost as though she knew about the technique and its flaws.

"What?!"

Before the man could react, Meixiu suddenly extended her arm and grabbed the man's neck with a claw-like hand.

The man's eyes widened with surprise, but he subconsciously reacted and used both his arm to grab Meixiu's slender arm to try and pull it away.

However, he quickly realized that even with two hands, he was unable to remove Meixiu's arm that was clutching onto his neck, almost like it was made of steel and permanently attached to his neck.

"W-Wait... L-Let's talk—"

A cracking noise resounded midway through the man's sentence, silencing him.

The man's body immediately limped afterward.

"Y-You killed him?" The remaining two invaders were in disbelief when they saw Meixiu's merciless action. How could someone so beautiful and seemingly so innocent take another life so casually?

Meixiu released her clutch on the man's neck, dropping his body on the floor.

"So what if I killed him? It's self-defense." Meixiu then spoke in a cold voice that sent chills down their spine.

"Y-You're fucking crazy! You won't get away with murder even if you use self-defense to justify it! And you killed two people!"

"And there will be two more corpses if you don't leave us alone," Meixiu said.

"F-Fuck! I am outta here! I am not getting paid enough to risk my life with this psycho!" One of them suddenly turned around and ran towards the emergency staircase, not even bothering to take the elevator.

Seeing his comrade leave, the remaining person there also decided to leave, as there was no chance that he was going to fight Meixiu alone.

"You better enjoy your last moments here since you'll be going behind bars soon!" The man said to her before disappearing from the scene.

Once the invaders left, Meixiu released a sigh of relief.

She then retrieved her phone and dialed a number.

A moment later, Meifeng's voice resounded, "What happened?"

"They broke into our apartment," said Meixiu.

"..."

After a moment of silence, Meifeng finally responded, "Since you are able to call me, I will assume that you've taken care of it."

"Yes, I took care of it... But I might have gone a little overboard," she said.

"You killed them?" Meifeng asked in a solemn voice.

"No... I held back my strength as much as possible, but they will definitely die if they don't receive any medical care soon."

"Haaaaa..." Meifeng sighed out loud.

Then she said, "Call the police. I will be there soon."

"Okay."

Meixiu then hung up and called the cops to explain the situation to them.

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Chapter 492 The Police Arrives

Once the noises stopped, Yuan shouted out loud in a nervous voice from his bedroom, "Meixiu! Are you okay?!"

Since his Divine Sense wasn't powerful enough to see what was going on at the door, he had no idea what had transpired— only that they had been invaded and Meixiu was dealing with the invaders.

"I am okay." Meixiu's voice resounded a moment later.

And she continued, "I have driven away the invaders, but it might get a little rowdy here since I have just called the police."

"Thank heavens you're fine..." Yuan released a sigh of relief after hearing her calm voice.

Sometime later, Meixiu entered the room so that Yuan could actually see that she was okay, and she proceeded to explain the situation to him.

"I can't believe they actually broke into our home to try and take you away..." Yuan said with a deep frown on his face. It has been a while since he felt this much anger, and all of this was caused by the Cultivators' Association and the Yu Family.

"I didn't want to blow this situation up so I reported it to the police as a random robbery. Even if we tell them that the Yu Family had hired them to take me back, they wouldn't believe it, and I'm sure the Yu Family will have some sort of excuse ready in case they get investigated."

"Despicable!" Yuan muttered in a suppressed voice.

He didn't feel this angry when the Yu Family abandoned him, nor when they kicked him out of the house. However, breaking into their home and trying to force Meixiu back had caused him to feel emotions that he didn't know were possible.

What would have happened if Meixiu didn't have the capabilities to protect herself? Yuan didn't even dare to imagine it.

"What's going to happen now?" He asked her after calming down.

"Well, the police are on their way here, but so is my mother. We'll just have to see how things go." Meixiu said in a calm voice.

"You're awfully calm about this situation, Meixiu." Yuan noticed this and said.

"I guess... But panicking won't help. Though I think it's mostly because I know that my mother will be here." Meixiu said.

Sometime later, the police arrived at their apartment along with some ambulances to take care of the two unconscious men that were on the verge of dying.

"Can you tell me what happened?" The police officer asked Meixiu with his notepad and pen in his hands.

Meixiu nodded and proceeded to recall the situation.

"I was cultivating like usual, but then I heard some weird noises coming from the door, so I decided to investigate. However, right as I reached the door, I suddenly heard the door unlocking by itself. It was at this moment that I knew someone had broken into our home, so I prepared myself for the worse."

"The invaders entered through the door the next moment, and I unconsciously punched the first person who entered, taking him by surprise. Then I proceeded to fight the second person. When I defeated him as well, the last two invaders ran away, and that's when I called the police."

The police were left dumbfounded by Meixiu's story. How can a single girl with a delicate appearance like Meixiu fight off four adult men by herself?

"Are you by any chance a cultivator?" One of them asked her.

"Yes, I am." She nodded.

"I am also not used to my new strength, so when I fought back, I might have used a little too much strength..." Meixiu said.

"Y-Yeah... We can see that from their injuries. According to the medics, one of the men had a broken jaw while the other had his neck crushed. It's a miracle that the latter one is still alive."

"What about you, young man? Can we hear your side of the story?"

The police then asked Yuan, who was sitting in the wheelchair.

"I don't know. I only heard the commotion when Meixiu fought the invaders."

"Okay. Anyway, please sit tight while we speak with your neighbors to see if they have anything else to say."

The police then went to knock on their neighbors' door.

However, all of them were either asleep or playing Cultivation Online, and the commotion wasn't loud enough to wake them up.

Shortly after the police spoke with their neighbors, Meifeng showed up to the scene with a cold expression on her face.

"Excuse me, who are you?" One of the policemen stopped her.

"I am her mother." Meifeng pointed at Meixiu, and she continued, "I rushed here after receiving news of what had occurred."

"I see..."

The police allowed her to enter the place after confirming her identity.

"What's going to happen now?" Meifeng asked the police.

"We can't really say anything until those two unconscious men wake up and we get their side of the story, not to mention the other two who ran away. However, if this is really a robbery, then we'll make sure justice is served. As for their injuries caused by the young lady, it'll be considered self-defense. They might try to sue her later for the damages since their injuries are quite severe, but that will be up to the court."

"I understand. Thank you." Meifeng said to them.

"We will contact you again later." After taking down Meixiu and Meifeng's contact information, the police left the scene.

Once they were gone, Meifeng sat down in the living room with Meixiu and Yuan.

"Alright, tell me the whole story."

Meixiu nodded and recalled everything that had happened without skipping any details this time.

"They sent four cultivators with military experiences, huh? You dealt with them much easier than I'd expected. What's your cultivation?" Meifeng then asked her.

"First Level Spirit Warrior... I had a breakthrough recently, too." Meixiu responded in a low voice.

Meifeng's eyes widened with surprise.

She didn't really believe it at first when they said Meixiu was talented in cultivation, but after learning her cultivation, Meifeng had no choice but to believe it.

Chapter 493 How Long Do You Plan On Sleeping?

"Miss Meifeng, is there anything you can do about this situation? Your word usually has a lot of weight within the Yu Family, especially with Yu Rou's father." Yuan asked her.

"Unfortunately, there is nothing I— or the Yu Family can do at this moment. Although the Yu Family hired those crooks to take Meixiu back, they are only doing it because of Chairman Zhao from the Cultivators' Association." Meifeng said.

"The Cultivators' Association is an incredibly powerful and influential background with the number of cultivators they have at their disposal, and they are only growing stronger by the day. The Yu Family does not wish to offend them, nor can they afford to, so they can only agree to help them obtain Meixiu."

"They're all treating Meixiu like some kind of object that can be owned because they want her! I have had enough of this! Miss Meifeng, take me to the Cultivators' Association tomorrow! I am going to speak with the Chairman." Yuan suddenly said, taking them by surprise.

"What? You're going to speak with him? Even if you do that, he has no reason to listen to you, and there's a good chance that he won't even meet you, much less speak with you." Meifeng said to him.

"Don't worry, I have a plan," Yuan said.

Meixiu and Meifeng turned to look at each other.

"Young Master, we can talk about this tomorrow. It's already super late, so you should get some rest for now. I will stay here with you tonight." Meifeng said.

"Really?" Yuan said, his voice filled with excitement.

"Yes, I will even share the bed with you... If you don't mind, that is."

"I don't!" Yuan immediately responded.

"Then allow me to get you to bed."

Meifeng then picked Yuan up from his wheelchair and carried him to his bedroom with ease.

"Miss Meifeng, are you cultivating?" Yuan suddenly asked her.

"Unfortunately, I have yet to start since I am usually busy with my work. Though I do intend on starting soon," she said.

"I see... Then do you have a cultivation technique yet? If not, I can help you obtain one." Yuan then said, surprising her a little.

"It's okay, Young Master. The Yu Family has a Heaven-grade cultivation technique they're willing to let me borrow. Even Yu Rou is currently using this cultivation technique, you know?" Meifeng said as she placed him on the bed.

"If you say so..."

"I will be back in a minute," Meifeng said a moment later before leaving the room to speak with Meixiu.

"Go get some rest. We will continue this tomorrow."

"Okay."

Meixiu nodded and entered her room shortly after.

Meifeng then returned to Yuan's room and got onto the bed with him, sleeping beside him.

"How long has it been since we last shared a bed?" Meifeng suddenly mumbled in a low voice.

"Too long..." Yuan said with a bittersweet smile on his face.

Meifeng closed her eyes, quickly falling asleep, as it was incredibly late into the night.

Yuan also fell asleep a few minutes later.

Shortly after Yuan fell asleep, unbeknownst to him or Meifeng, his body suddenly began emitting a faint golden glow, and within his body, the golden symbols were beginning to change, transforming into lines that resembled veins, eventually connecting with the other golden symbols.

Once all of the golden symbols within his body were connected, it began emitting a unique aura that caused the entire world to tremble.

However, since it was a relatively small earthquake and both Meifeng and Yuan were deep in their sleep, neither of them noticed it.

Only Meixiu, who couldn't sleep, had felt the earthquake.

As for Yuan's body, it was covered in these golden lines that looked like veins.

Furthermore, the Celestial Water he'd consumed in Cultivation Online finally started showing its true effects, allowing the golden veins to fully absorb it.

Indeed, most of the Celestial Water had actually been inactive until this point, and Yuan's significant boost in cultivation speed and improvements to his Divine Sense was only a small portion of the Celestial Water's power.

Once the golden symbols that were now golden veins absorbed the Celestial Water, it unattached itself from Yuan's bones and combined with his

meridians, instantly doubling the size of his meridians, allowing spiritual energy to flow through them much quicker and more efficiently.

Every single time Yuan breathed, even though he wasn't actively cultivating, his body would absorb a massive amount of spiritual energy in the room, quickly emptying out the spiritual energy in his apartment.

When the spiritual energy in his room was completely absorbed by Yuan, his body would start to absorb a larger area until he started absorbing even the spiritual energy in the others' apartment, then it would expand to outside their apartment.

Eventually, the spiritual energy within the city started to disappear at a rapid rate, as it was all being absorbed by Yuan unconsciously.

This phenomenon shocked every cultivator in the city, as they were forced to stop cultivating due to the lack of spiritual energy in the city, and for the rest of the night, nobody living within Yuan's city was able to cultivate.

Meanwhile, Yuan's body unconsciously hoarded all of the spiritual energy in the city.

However, despite the massive amount of spiritual energy entering his body, Yuan's cultivation base remained untouched, almost as though it didn't receive any spiritual energy.

The golden vein in his body was a different story, as it began growing more and more veins until it literally covered every inch of Yuan's body from head to toe.

Eventually, the golden veins stopped glowing and appearing outside his body.

Meanwhile, inside Yuan's dream that started almost immediately after he fell asleep, Yuan stood before a massive jade tablet that had the word 'Destiny' engraved into it.

Of course, this wasn't Yuan's first time dreaming of this place, as it would appear inside his dream at least once a week ever since he awakened his bloodline.

However, there was something different about the dream this time, as he was not alone in this place.

Standing a few meters in front of him and before the jade tablet was a tall figure wearing black robes, silently emitting a divine aura that made it seem like he was there yet he wasn't at the same time.

Yuan was certain that he never met this figure, nor could he see this person's face— only his straight back that oozes with confidence, yet he felt a familiar feeling from this person for some reason.

"W-Who are you?" Yuan decided to ask him after standing there in silence for a good minute.

"You need to wake up soon..." This person responded in a calm voice.

"Excuse me?"

The man turned around, showing his handsome face that somewhat resembled Yuan's face, but it was much more mature and handsome.

"How long do you plan on sleeping? If you sleep any longer, all of my—our effort will be in vain." The handsome man said.

And he continued, "Your woman is in danger, yet the only thing you can do is lay there and wait for her to be taken away from you. How pathetic. If it were me, I'd take my sword and slay everyone involved."

Yuan was speechless. Just who is this man and what is he talking about? And most importantly, why is he having this dream?

Chapter 494 Waking Up

"You're still here? If you don't wake up soon, you'll forever remain useless." The handsome man suddenly said.

"I don't quite understand... Even if I want to wake up, I cannot wake up until I finish this dream. It's been like this for many weeks now." Yuan said.

The handsome man sighed and snapped his fingers, suddenly changing the scenery from the jade tablet to the peak of some unknown mountain.

On this mountain, there were countless swords stabbed into the ground, looking like a graveyard for swords or something of that sort.

"Where are we?" Yuan asked.

"You don't remember?" The handsome man asked him.

"Why would I remember something I have never seen before?"

"..."

The handsome man silently looked at him with a pondering look.

He then spoke in a sighing voice, "Looks like the curses had affected you worse than I'd anticipated."

"Huh? You know about the curses?" Yuan's eyes widened with surprise.

"Of course."

"Then can you tell me more about it?"

However, to Yuan's surprise, the handsome man said, "Nah."

"Eh?"

"Learning about the curses in your current condition won't do you any good. In fact, it might even harm you. Therefore, I won't say anything for now."

"Then can you at least tell me who you are?" Yuan asked for his identity again.

The handsome man smiled, and he began approaching Yuan.

Once he was standing right in front of Yuan, he said, "You really have no idea?"

Yuan frowned, and he proceeded to stare at the man's face while trying to figure out if he'd seen this man before.

However, no matter how hard he thought, he was unable to remember anything.

He eventually shook his head, "I don't know you."

"You don't know me, yet I somehow appeared in your dreams. You don't dream about people you have never seen before, you know? Somewhere deep in your mind— your soul remembers me. That's why I am here."

"Even if you tell me that, I can't remember what I don't remember." Yuan sighed.

"Then why don't I nudge your memories a little?" The handsome man suddenly retrieved a beautiful sword from thin air and pointed it at Yuan.

"Fight me."

"What?" Yuan looked at him with wide eyes.

"Fight me." The handsome man repeated.

"I don't even have a weapon."

"This is your dream. Just imagine one."

Hearing his words, Yuan imagined the Empyrean Overlord.

When the handsome man saw the large sword in Yuan's grasp, he smiled and said, "So you decided to use his sword, huh?"

"You know this sword?" Yuan asked.

"Of course. You don't?" The handsome man asked him, once again implying that he should also know about it.

"I—"

However, right as Yuan opened his mouth to speak, the handsome man suddenly stepped forward and attacked.

Yuan quickly reacted to the strike, blocking it.

"Not bad... But you're still too weak."

The sword in the man's hand suddenly disappeared, reappearing right next to Yuan's neck.

Yuan subconsciously used his movement technique to barely dodge it, but the sword had managed to reach his neck and created a small cut on it.

Yuan could feel his blood dripping down his neck; it was an incredibly realistic feeling, almost like he wasn't dreaming at all.

The handsome man then continued to attack Yuan, giving him no time to breathe.

The onslaught continued for a few minutes until Yuan's entire body was filled with superficial cuts.

"You're weak. Too weak. How will you protect your loved ones when you're in such a pathetic state?" The handsome man eventually stopped attacking him and asked.

"Y-You're just too powerful..." Yuan responded in an exhausted manner while kneeling on the ground.

Compared to Feng Yuxiang, this handsome man was on another level. Although he felt hopeless when he sparred with Feng Yuxiang, this mysterious man gave him a feeling of dread and despair.

"Of course, I am powerful." The man didn't deny it, even confirming it in a somewhat narcissistic tone.

He then continued, "You can only survive when you're powerful. That's why if you continue to remain that weak, you'll die."

"Anyways, we have wasted enough time. If you don't wake up soon, you'll really regret it."

"I can't control when I wake up." Yuan shook his head.

"I know— because you're weak. However, I am different. I am strong, so I will wake you up."

The handsome suddenly took a stance that Yuan had never seen before, yet he found it very nostalgic for some reason.

"It's a sword technique..." Yuan subconsciously muttered in a low voice.

The handsome man responded with a profound smile on his face, "Yes, you're right. It's a sword technique, and it's called the Immortal Rending Sword Strike. Remember it well."

The next moment, Yuan watched as the man moved his hand and swung the sword, sending a massive wave of energy that felt like Sword Qi at him.

Yuan's vision blackened instantly after the attack consumed him, and he could feel his body again.

'I am awake?' Yuan quickly realized this.

"Hmm? What's this soft feeling?" Yuan then noticed a soft and round sensation in his hand, and his body subconsciously commanded his hand to squeeze it.

"Mmm..."

A weird noise suddenly resounded beside him.

In a daze, Yuan squeezed it a couple more times.

"Aaah..."

A gentle moan responded.

Then—

"Y-Young Master...?" Meifeng's shocked voice resounded the next moment.

Yuan frowned at the situation. He decided to use his Divine Sense to see what was happening, and to his surprise, he noticed that his left hand was directly on top of Meifeng's large assets on her chest.

"Whoa! I am so sorry! I didn't mean to do that!" Yuan's body subconsciously reacted and quickly removed his hand.

However, Meifeng didn't care about that at all. In fact, her mind was occupied by something else.

"Y-Young Master... You... Your body..."

Meifeng stared at him with her eyes as wide as saucers.

"What?"

It was at this moment Yuan realized that he was no longer lying in the bed.

Instead, he was sitting on it.

Furthermore, he was doing it effortlessly, almost as though there was no longer anything restricting his body.

However, he wasn't in Cultivation Online, so he shouldn't be able to achieve such a feat.

'A-Am I actually still dreaming?' Yuan wondered to himself, as that was the only logical explanation for this phenomenon.

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Chapter 495 Standing On His Own

"I... I must be dreaming..." Yuan mumbled in a voice filled with disbelief as he moved his arms around without any effort.

He was barely able to move his arms last night, yet he suddenly had the ability to sit up on the bed and move around effortlessly?

"Y-Young Master... I-I don't think you're dreaming..." Meifeng said to him in a low voice.

Yuan subconsciously turned his head to look in Meifeng's direction, but he was still blind. However, that didn't matter to him. Even if he remains blind for the rest of his life, as long as he can move his body properly, he will be satisfied.

"What happened, Young Master? Why can you suddenly... move?" Meifeng asked him, silently wondering to herself if she was actually the one dreaming.

Although she was happy for him, she was also worried about the sudden phenomenon.

"I... I don't know. My body just started working again... Almost like when my body suddenly stopped working many years ago," he said, still in disbelief.

After a moment of silence, Yuan decided to try and get off the bed by himself.

He took a deep breath, then he started moving his body off the bed.

Meifeng watched with a nervous look on her beautiful face, feeling like a mother watching her baby walking on their own for the first time.

A moment later, Yuan managed to stand up on his own beside the bed after a little struggle.

Despite having no trouble moving his body in Cultivation Online, it was an entirely different feeling in the real world, as his body hasn't physically stood up in many years.

"Young Master..."

Meifeng suddenly felt an urge to cry, and before she even realized it, tears were already flowing down her face.

Seeing Yuan stand up on his own had overwhelmed her, who had always dreamt about seeing it happen.

Once he was used to the feeling of standing up, Yuan began moving his legs, trying to walk.

However, since his body wasn't used to moving for so long, it was a new challenge for him.

"Oh!"

Yuan even fell down a couple of times.

"Young Master, please hold my hand." Meifeng got out of bed to assist him.

Yuan grabbed her hand and started moving back and forth in the bedroom while being supported by Meifeng, feeling like a patient during rehabilitation.

"How do you feel, Young Master?" Meifeng asked him a few minutes later.

"I can move my body just fine, but since I haven't moved this much in a while, it feels like my body is having trouble listening to all of my

commands. However, I am starting to get used to the feeling of moving again."

"Okay, let's continue this for a little longer," Meifeng said.

Thus, Yuan continued to practice his movements in the bedroom with Meifeng.

Sometime later, Meixiu got out of her bed and started preparing for breakfast.

While she cooked breakfast, Meixiu heard the door to Yuan's room open.

"Good morning, mother," Meixiu said without looking back.

There was no response from Meifeng, but Meixiu was used to receiving no response so she didn't think much of it and continued to cook breakfast.

A few moments later, Meixiu could feel a presence approaching her from behind.

"Do you need some help?"

Yuan's voice suddenly resounded, but it sounded too close to her, causing Meixiu to raise her eyebrows.

She then turned around, and to her complete shock, Yuan was standing right behind her with a smile on his face.

"Whoa?!"

Meixiu took a step back and nearly knocked down the cooking pan, looking like she'd just witnessed a ghost.

"Y-Y-You... You're standing?!" Meixiu exclaimed in a shocked voice.

"That's right. It's pretty cool, right?" Yuan chuckled.

"Oh, I'm sorry if I scared you just now. I only wanted to surprise you," he added.

Meixiu then silently looked up and down at Yuan to make sure she was seeing it properly. Once she confirmed that Yuan was actually standing, she rubbed her eyes and even pinched her own cheeks to make sure she wasn't dreaming.

"You're not dreaming, Meixiu. It's real. The Young Master can move properly now." Meifeng said to her from Yuan's bedroom.

"Why... How...?" Meixiu had so many questions that she didn't know where to start.

"Sorry, but I don't know either. I woke up being able to move." Yuan said.

"You woke up like that...?" Meixiu looked at him with a dumbfounded face.

How does that even work? A miracle?

"I don't know what to say... congratulations on your recovery?" Meixiu said a moment later.

His recovery was so sudden that Meixiu was still trying to fully grasp the situation.

"Meixiu."

Yuan suddenly spread his arms with a smile on his face, his desires obvious.

Meixiu looked at Meifeng, who was still standing by Yuan's room and staring at her with a profound gaze.

"How long are you going to make him wait?" Meifeng said to her a moment later.

Meixiu immediately began blushing.

She then approached Yuan and accepted his hug.

"I have wanted to do this for a long time now," he said as he tightened his embrace on her.

"Now that I can move again, I promise you that I won't let anyone bully you anymore."

Hearing Yuan's words, the redness on Meixiu's face fully blossomed.

Once Yuan was satisfied, he let her go and said, "Alright, I will let you finish breakfast now. If you need help, let me know."

"It's okay, I got it."

Sometime later, once breakfast was ready, they sat around the table in the living room with more food than usual since Meifeng was there as well.

Of course, it felt surreal for all three of them to be sitting together like they were a real family.

"What are your plans now, Young Master?" Meifeng asked him after breakfast while Meixiu cleaned the dishes.

"There's a lot of things I want to do, such as giving the Cultivators' Association a piece of my mind, but first, I need to get used to moving my body again," he said.

Chapter 496 50 Billion Dollars

"Although you can move again, I suggest you let Doctor Wang take a look at your body just in case," Meifeng said.

"You're right. I will call him now."

"Umm... Can I borrow your phone?" Yuan asked Meixiu.

Once he had Meixiu's phone, Yuan personally called Doctor Wang.

Now that he could finally move properly, he wanted to do everything for himself no matter how little the thing is.

"Good morning, Meixiu." Doctor Wang's voice resounded a moment later.

"Hello, Doctor Wang."

"Hmm? This voice... The Young Master?"

"Yes. I am wondering when will you be free? I'd like you to come and take a look at my condition. Oh, can you bring Wang Xiuying here as well if possible?"

"You need the both of us there to check your condition? That doesn't sound good. Did something happen?" Doctor Wang asked in a worried voice.

"Yes, something insane happened."

"Can you explain it to me through the phone?"

"I could, but I think it would be better for you to see it for yourselves," said Yuan with a smile on his face.

"Though you don't have to rush here. Take your time."

Hearing this, Doctor Wang thought to himself that if the situation wasn't urgent enough to rush them, it probably isn't that bad.

However, he didn't want to take any chances.

"I understand. I will try to show up as soon as possible, and I will also let Wang Xiuying know."

"Thank you, Doctor Wang. I will see you later."

After Yuan hung up, Meifeng asked him, "Young Master, I must ask you this now that you're able to move again... Do you intend on playing the instrument again?"

"Playing the instrument, huh..." Yuan pondered for a moment before speaking, "After playing the zither in Cultivation Online, I have realized that I don't hate playing music or instruments. Instead, it was the Yu Family that made everything feel like a chore. In other words, yes, I want to continue playing the instruments, but I won't return to the professional scene."

"I see..."

A warm smile appeared on Meifeng's face.

"Speaking of instruments, I don't have any of them..." Yuan then said.

"It's okay, I can buy some for you," Meifeng said.

And she continued, "I have many connections in the music industry after working for the Yu Family for many years, so I know who to contact for instruments. What do you have in mind? I can buy them for you, too."

Yuan shook his head and said, "It's okay, Miss Meifeng, you don't need to pay for them. We should have enough money to buy the instruments on our own."

"If you're talking about the money Meixiu saved up from working, I don't think it'll be enough..."

"We'd earned a decent amount of money from selling treasures we find in Cultivation Online on the auction house," he said.

"Even if you say that, instruments aren't cheap, especially not the ones I intend on buying you. They're all created by famous companies with centuries of experience. You only deserve to play on the best of the best instruments, after all."

"We have half a billion, so money isn't an issue for us right now." Meixiu suddenly said after returning from cleaning the dishes.

"Half a billion...? You earned that much through selling treasures in Cultivation Online?" Meifeng was speechless.

Although she was aware of how profitable playing Cultivation Online was, she didn't think it was possible to earn that much money in such a short time.

Yuan nodded, "We got pretty lucky."

Sometime later, Meixiu looked at her mother and asked, "Don't you need to be at work?"

"I took a vacation three days ago, so I don't have to go back to work for another week," she said, as she had anticipated that something might happen to them after learning that the Yu Family intended to take Meixiu back forcefully, so she took a week off just in case.

"Miss Meifeng... Would you leave the Yu Family if you had the chance?" Yuan suddenly asked her.

"It isn't easy leaving the Yu Family, as I am bound to a contract with the Yu Family. If I want to leave before my contract is finished, I must pay an exorbitant amount of money, and the Yu Family must also agree to let me go, which is highly unlikely." Meifeng said.

"When will the contract end?" Yuan then asked.

"50 years."

"F-Fifty years?!" Yuan was shocked to hear this.

"The contract started out as 5 years, but they continued to increase the duration until it reached 50 years. I didn't mind it either since I got paid a lot of money and I had no reason to refuse."

"Out of curiosity... How much do you have to pay if you want to leave the Yu Family?" Yuan asked her.

"Fifty billion dollars— one billion for every year on the contract."

"Fifty billion..." Yuan repeated in a low voice.

Unless Meifeng borrowed money from others, there was simply no way that she'd be able to pay such an exorbitant amount.

"Anyways, I don't really have any reasons to leave the Yu Family right now. Despite their recent actions against Meixiu, it was mostly due to the influence of the Cultivators' Association, and they don't treat me badly either. While I have a lot of work to do, I am already used to it by now, and I am compensated for it with generous pay."

After a slight pause, Meifeng continued, "However... If the Young Master asks me to leave the Yu Family to work for him, I will have a good reason to leave."

"You can stay at the Yu Family. I can take care of him by myself just fine." Meixiu suddenly said while staring at Meifeng with an ambitious look on his face.

Meifeng smiled inwardly at Meixiu's words.

"Don't worry, I won't steal the Young Master from you. With that being said, I will stay here until my vacation is over, as the incident from last

night hasn't concluded just yet." Meifeng said a moment later, reminding them that they might still be in danger.

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Chapter 497 Nearly Had a Heart Attack

After breakfast ended Yuan continued to practice his movements by walking around the house, while Meifeng and Meixiu watched him from the couch.

"Young Master, I have been wondering for a while now, but how do you know where to go if you cannot see where you're going?" Meifeng suddenly asked him.

Although Yuan has recovered his ability to move his body, he was still blind, meaning he shouldn't be able to see where he was going.

"Oh, I can see just fine with Divine Sense." Yuan casually said.

"Divine Sense? What's that?" Meifeng asked, as she wasn't familiar with the cultivation world.

"I can basically see things around me as though I have eyes above my body without using my eyes, and the stronger my Divine Sense the further I can see. It's something cultivators can do after reaching a certain cultivation, I guess."

"I see... What a mythical power... Now I also want to start cultivating as soon as possible." Meifeng mumbled to herself.

About three hours later, someone suddenly started knocking on their door.

"It's me, Doctor Wang!"

Doctor Wang's voice resounded from outside.

Hearing his voice, Meixiu got off the couch, but before she could go anywhere, Yuan said, "I got it."

Meixiu looked at him for a moment before nodding her head.

Yuan then walked to the door and took a deep breath before opening the door.

"Welcome, Doctor Wang. Welcome, Xiuying." Yuan greeted them with a smile on his face after opening the door.

Clang!

Doctor Wang dropped the metal box in his hand that carried his tools when he saw Yuan standing before him at the door.

"Y-Y-You..."

Wang Xiuying pointed at him with trembling hands.

"You're standing?!" Doctor Wang exclaimed in a shocked voice, finishing the sentence Wang Xiuying couldn't utter.

Yuan lowered his body and picked up the metal box dropped by Doctor Wang before speaking, "Surprised?"

"H-How?" Wang Xiuying asked him a moment later.

"Let's continue this inside, shall we?" Yuan said as he walked back into the apartment.

However, both Doctor Wang and Wang Xiuying remained standing outside with a dazed look on their faces.

It was not until Yuan invited them inside again that they finally began moving.

"Madam Meifeng, you're here as well?" Doctor Wang was surprised to see her in the living room.

"A lot has happened," she calmly said.

Doctor Wang turned to look at Yuan, who was standing a few meters away, and nodded, "I bet..."

Once everyone was seated, Doctor Wang spoke again, "What happened to you, Young Master? How come you can move again? I nearly had a heart attack just now."

Yuan showed a bittersweet smile and shrugged, "I wish I could tell you, but I can't. I woke up like this."

"What? You woke up fully recovered?" Wang Xiuying's jaw dropped after hearing this, as she expected him to say that he'd recovered after eating some heaven-defying treasure in Cultivation Online that affected his real body.

"Yes," he nodded.

"I didn't really do anything special. When I woke up this morning, my body had magically recovered."

"It's a miracle..." Doctor Wang mumbled in a low voice.

"Congratulations, Yu Tian! You have finally recovered! I knew you'd recover one day!" Wang Xiuying suddenly started congratulating him.

Even though Yuan had recovered without her help, she didn't feel bad at all. No matter how Yuan recovered—with or without her help, Wang Xiuying was just happy to see him finally recover.

"Thank you, but only my body has recovered. I am still blind. Also, I want to see if there are any changes to my body, that's why I called you here." Yuan then said.

Doctor Wang nodded, "I understand."

Sometime later, Yuan laid on his bed while Doctor Wang and Wang Xiuying inspected his body.

After getting the results, Doctor Wang said, "Judging by the results, your body hasn't changed much since your last checkup. However, we can't really say for sure since this was done with basic equipment. Unless you get a more detailed examination at the hospital, we can't really say if your body had any significant changes."

"I see... I can't go to the hospital now since I am in the middle of something troublesome, but I will definitely visit you once I am able to." Yuan said.

"Something troublesome? Did something happen?" Wang Xiuying asked him.

"Well... It's a little complicated but..."

Yuan proceeded to explain to them their situation with the Cultivators' Association and what transpired yesterday night.

"What a bunch of arrogant and entitled pricks!" Wang Xiuying exclaimed after hearing the story, feeling incredibly angry.

Even Doctor Wang couldn't help but frown. He then said, "Chairman Zhao is actually a patient of mine. I will speak with him later and try to convince him to stop this farce."

However, Yuan shook his head and said, "It's okay, Doctor Wang. I don't want to drag your family into this as well. I will deal with Chairman Zhao myself."

"A-Are you sure...?" Doctor Wang had a worried frown on his face.

"Yes, I have a plan," Yuan confirmed.

"If you say so..."

"What are your plans now that you're able to move again? Are you going to return to the music industry? I really want to hear your music again." Wang Xiuying asked him a moment later.

Yuan smiled and said, "If you want to hear my music, you can visit me anytime and I will play for you. I won't return to the music industry, though."

"Really?! It's a promise!" Wang Xiuying said, her body trembling from excitement.

A private performance from Yuan was something she'd dreamt of ever since she was a kid!

"Just let me get some instruments first, okay? I am empty-handed right now," he said.

"Oh! I have a piano at home! If you want, I can give it to you! I rarely play it anymore, anyway!" Wang Xiuying said, donating her piano to him.

"If you don't need it, I will take it off your hands."

"Then it's decided! I will have it delivered to you by tomorrow!"

Yuan nodded.

Chapter 498 Grow Up

"Alright, I have to return to the hospital now. You can stay here if you like, Xiuying." Doctor Wang said after chatting with Yuan for about half an hour.

"See you later, Doctor Wang," Yuan said to him.

"Yes, I will see you later. Once again, I am so glad that you've finally recovered. Let's hope it only gets better from this point."

Doctor Wang left the place, but Wang Xiuying decided to stay there for a little longer.

"I still can't believe..." Wang Xiuying mumbled in a low voice as she watched Yuan practice his movements by walking around the house.

"Hmm? How come you know where to go?" Wang Xiuying quickly realized this, as she wasn't aware that he could use divine sense in the real world.

"It's divine sense," Meixiu explained to her.

"Wait... That divine sense?" Wang Xiuying's eyes widened with shock.

Although Meifeng didn't know the significance behind divine sense, Wang Xiuying did.

"Yes." Meixiu nodded.

"Unbelievable..."

Once Yuan was comfortable with his movements, he started doing exercises such as sit-ups and push-ups.

Since he was a peak Spirit Warrior, strength and endurance weren't an issue for Yuan. It was only a matter of his form.

Ten push-ups... twenty... thirty...

Fifty... one hundred...

Yuan managed to achieve a hundred push-ups and sit-ups without any breaks and still had plenty of energy left by the end of it.

Meanwhile, Wang Xiuying called a moving company to move her piano to their apartment.

"Alright, it's about time for me to leave. The piano should be here tomorrow afternoon," she said to them afterward.

And she continued, "I will also be here tomorrow to listen to you playing."

"Okay. See you later." Yuan said.

Yuan then proceeded to continue his exercise, working up a good sweat.

"I am going to take a shower," Yuan said to them.

"Do you need help?" Meixiu subconsciously asked him since she was used to it.

"It's okay, I got it," Yuan said before entering the bathroom.

Once Yuan entered the bathroom, Meifeng looked at Meixiu with a mocking smile, "Looks like you're no longer needed now that he's recovered."

"Nonsense." Meixiu quickly responded.

"Oh? Then what can you do for him now that he can do everything himself?"

"I-I can still do the housework such as cleaning and cooking," she said.

"So basically a housewife? Are you going to assist him in the bed too?" Meifeng suddenly asked.

Meixiu immediately recalled their last shower together and blushed.

Of course, Meifeng was unaware of this, and she continued, "You know it's going to happen sooner or later. The Young Master may still be an innocent child now, but he will eventually mature and experience actual puberty."

"Once that happens, he will need a real woman to look after him. If you're not going to stand up for that position, someone will take him away from you, and you will truly no longer be needed at that time."

"I hope you still remember what I taught you."

Meixiu stared at Meifeng with a deep frown. As much as she wanted to refute Meifeng's claims, she knew that everything her mother said was the truth.

"You're already an adult, yet you haven't matured yet. Grow up, Meixiu. You have the perfect opportunity to establish your position right now. If you let this chance get away, you'll regret it when the Young Master returns to his ordinary life and becomes surrounded by even more women."

"If I were in your shoes, I would already be pregnant by now."

Meixiu was left speechless by her mother's last sentence.

Meanwhile, somewhere in the city, Mister Johnson stood before the two cultivators that had abandoned their mission with a deep frown on his face.

"Four grown men with over 10 years of military experience, yet you somehow lost to a little girl half your age, even running away with your tails tucked between your legs. Do you understand the word shame? This is what you get for underestimating Meixiu when I specifically warned you to not underestimate her."

Hearing Mister Johnson's lecture, the two cultivators didn't dare to utter a single word.

"Johnson... That bitch killed Scorpion and Hawk... Is there anything we can do to avenge them?"

Mister Johnson remained silent for a moment before speaking, "How can you be so sure that they're dead?"

"We watched that bitch snap Hawk's neck without mercy! There's no way he's still alive after that brutal strike!"

"Even Scorpion had his neck twisted in a weird angle by a single punch!"

Mister Johnson then said, "They are still alive."

"W-What? Really? How do you know that?"

"You think I don't have friends in the police force? They told me about the incident that had been marked as a robbery. Scorpion and Hawk had been taken to the hospital. They were on the verge of death when they arrived at the hospital, but they're not dead."

The other two released a sigh of relief after hearing that their comrades were still alive.

"I wouldn't relax now if I were you. They may be alive, but they're currently in custody. I will have to speak with my buddies if they don't want to go to jail." Mister Johnson said.

"What about the mission?" One of them asked.

"The mission is a failure. Now that you've caused a commotion, we can no longer continue, or we will risk being investigated. I'm not particularly worried about being investigated, but our clients, the Yu Family, definitely won't be happy if they're investigated, so we can only wait until things calm down for now."

"W-What about our pay?"

Mister Johnson sneered and said, "You still have the guts to ask for money after your embarrassing failure?! I wouldn't be surprised if the Yu Family

asks for compensation for this failure! If that happens, it's coming out of your accounts!"

"What?! No way!"

After dealing with the two idiots, Mister Johnson had to call the Yu Family to let them know the result of the mission, which was a complete failure.

Obviously, the Yu Family wasn't happy when they heard this news, and they immediately demanded a full refund.

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Chapter 499 Aiming to Be the First

"You failed the mission?! Don't give me this bullshit! I paid millions so you could do your damn job! I demand a full refund!" Yu Yong shouted at his phone after receiving the news of their failure.

"Unfortunately, we have a no refund policy, and you have agreed to this term before hiring us. If you want us to try again, we can do so at a discounted price, but your family will be at risk of getting investigated. If you accept this risk, we will go back and get Meixiu one more time after receiving more payment."

"Meixiu was stronger than any of us could have anticipated, so we will need more resources to take her back. I hope you understand."

Yu Yong didn't immediately respond. Although he didn't mind an investigation since he has plenty of lawyers and friends with power, it wouldn't look good for his company if news spread that he'd hired merchants to kidnap a girl.

However, as long as the news didn't spread, everything would be fine, and he had plenty of resources available to keep that from happening.

"How much?" Yu Yong asked after a moment of silence.

"10 million." Mister Johnson quickly responded.

"Ten million?! That's more than double what I paid you last time! And you consider that as a discount?! This is clearly a scam!" Yu Yong exclaimed.

"Yes, it's the discounted price. If not for the discount, I would have asked for 15 million. Since four cultivators between the 7th and 8th level weren't

enough to bring Meixiu back, we will have to increase our forces. I intend on bringing experts from around the world this time, so it will cost much more than usual."

Yu Yong coldly sneered, "Using this many resources just to bring back a little girl. Aren't you ashamed of yourselves?"

After a moment of silence, Mister Johnson said, "With all due respect, if you think you have what it takes to make her return, go ahead. I will send you their location in a moment since we were paid to do so."

"If you want to continue working with us, send the money by next week. If not, then this is the end of our cooperation. Once again, I apologize for the inconveniences."

Yu Yong hung up the phone after that and tossed it at the wall.

"A bunch of useless bastards!"

Seeing his reaction, Tang Lee said, "At least we have their location. We can have Yu Rou try to convince Meixiu to return."

Yu Yong looked at her with a pondering look, "Why didn't we think of that sooner? We could've saved millions! If it's Yu Rou, I'm sure that she'll convince Meixiu to return! Call her here!"

An hour later, Yu Rou arrived at their main location after being summoned by her parents.

"Yu Rou, we have a job for you." Yu Yong said to her with a solemn look on his face.

"..."

Yu Rou could already guess what they wanted from her, but she acted ignorantly and asked, "What is it, father?"

Yu Yong then handed her a piece of paper and said, "Meixiu is living here right now, and I want you to convince her to come back."

Yu Rou then said, "Why do you want Meixiu back? She left on her own accord, so I don't think she will return even if I ask her."

"That isn't for you to worry about." Tang Lee said, and she continued, "Just bring Meixiu back at all cost."

Yu Yong then added, "If you successfully bring Meixiu back, I can consider lifting your restriction and allow you to meet with Yu Tian again. After all, he's with Meixiu right now."

"Really?!" Yu Rou expressed excitement after hearing this.

"Then I will go see Meixiu tomorrow!"

Yu Yong laughed inwardly seeing how easy it was convincing Yu Rou to help them.

Sometime later, Yu Rou returned home.

'Since they're asking me for help, this must mean that the people they hired to bring Meixiu back have failed...'

Yu Rou had no problem agreeing to help her parents. After all, she was only told to convince Meixiu to return, and she gets to see her brother again in the process.

'I can't wait to see Meixiu and brother again tomorrow after so long...' Yu Rou went to sleep early on that day, as she wanted the day to be over as quickly as possible.

Meanwhile, after his shower, Yuan moved all of the furniture in the living room to the wall, freeing up a lot of space in the center of the room.

"What are you doing, Young Master?" Meifeng asked him.

"I want to practice something," he said.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan began moving his legs in an odd but rhythmic manner.

"Hmm? That's..." Meixiu quickly recognized what Yuan was trying to do.

"Ah!"

Yuan tripped on himself a couple of seconds into his weird movements.

"I don't understand..." Meifeng shook her head.

"It's a movement technique," he said.

"Huh?"

"A movement technique I learned in Cultivation Online. I want to try practicing it in the real world as well."

Indeed, Yuan was trying to learn the movement technique Vermilion Phoenix Dominating the Heavens. Since he could use Flying Daggers, it obviously meant that he could learn other techniques as well.

And what better technique than a movement technique that will help him improve his overall movement?

"A movement technique? Good luck, Young Master. There are a lot of people trying to do the same." Meifeng mumbled in a low voice.

"Eh?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

Meifeng then said, "Since we can use cultivation techniques from Cultivation Online, it only makes sense that other techniques could also be learned. Although nobody has managed to do so yet, there are plenty of people out there trying to become the first person to learn a technique that's not a cultivation technique."

"Is that so..."

"Of course, there's a good chance that someone out there has already succeeded but decided to keep it a secret."

"Most likely," Yuan said with a smile on his face.

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Chapter 500 What Do You Think of My Daughter?

Yuan practiced his movement technique until it was time for dinner.

After dinner, Yuan wanted to continue practicing, but Meifeng said, "Young Master, I get that you're excited about your recovery, but you shouldn't move around so much after eating. It's bad for your body."

"Furthermore, since you've only recently recovered, you shouldn't do such intensive exercises that could strain your body. We still don't know if you've actually fully recovered or not, after all."

"You're right, Miss Meifeng... I got ahead of myself because of this sudden recovery that might only be temporary. I shouldn't stress my body too much or it could go back to being crippled..." Yuan wasn't happy about restraining himself, but he agreed with Meifeng. They still don't know if his body is fully recovered or if it was just temporary. He could wake up tomorrow and return to being a cripple.

"Let's not say something so demoralizing, Young Master. I'm sure your body is fine now and it won't suddenly revert back to its previous state, but until we're confident that you're really okay, I wouldn't push my body so much if I were in your shoes." Meifeng said.

"I understand."

Sometime later, they prepared for bed.

Once they entered the bedroom, Meifeng suddenly asked him, "Young Master, how about a body massage? I heard that getting a massage after a

day of exercise will make everything more effective."

"If you don't mind." Yuan nodded.

"Please lie on the bed with your back facing the ceiling."

Once Yuan laid on the bed, Meifeng got on top of him and gently sat on his buttocks in a kneeling position.

"Will you be okay if I did this? Am I too heavy?" Meifeng asked him just in case.

"I am okay. You're not heavy at all." Yuan said, feeling two round and soft objects pressing on his butt.

"Great."

Meifeng then started her massage on Yuan's back, starting from his neck and shoulders.

"Aaahh... This feels great..." Yuan released a satisfied sigh.

"Thank you for the praises, Young Masters."

After massaging Yuan for a few minutes, Meifeng started speaking with him.

"Young Master, I have a few questions for you."

"What is it?"

"What do you think of my daughter, Meixiu?"

"What do I think of Meixiu?" Yuan repeated the question.

He then said, "She's a very important person to me, and I owe a great deal to Meixiu for assisting me. Without her company, I wouldn't have survived this long alone. I also admire her a lot for her work. Although I don't know

what it's like working her job, I know it's not an easy job and not something a girl her age should be doing normally."

"You're right, it's not easy working as a maid, especially not for the Yu Family, where the standards are many times higher. Even I cannot compare to her when I was her age, but I rarely praise her because I don't want her to feel complacent. I wouldn't be surprised if she hates me because of how I raised her, but looking at her now, I won't regret it even if she hates me." Meifeng said with a gentle smile on her face.

"I don't think Meixiu hates you, Miss Meifeng."

Meifeng chuckled a little before speaking, "Anyways, judging by your words, I will assume that you really like Meixiu. Is that right, Young Master?"

"Yes, I really like Meixiu," he responded without hesitation.

"Then would you mind living with her forever?"

"No, I wouldn't. In fact, I would actually prefer it if we could remain like this forever."

"Hmmm... That will be problematic..." Meifeng suddenly said.

"Eh? Why would it be problematic?"

"Why? Isn't it obvious? Because we don't know what Meixiu wants. Even if you want to be with her forever, what if she wants to leave in the future? What if she has to leave in the future when she wants to start her own family?"

Yuan was left speechless by her words, and he immediately began pondering.

"You're right... It's all up to Meixiu in the end. As much as I want to be with her forever, I can't force her to stay with me. She has her own life, as I have my own. Guess I can only enjoy our time together while it lasts..." Yuan sighed.

Yuan never really thought about Meixiu leaving since she told him that she wanted to be with him in the past. However, people will inevitably change as they grow older, so there was a chance that Meixiu might leave his side in the future.

"Let's not come to immediate conclusions, Young Master. Maybe Meixiu wants to stay with you forever as well. If you're worried, why don't you ask her? In fact, I know how you can stay with her forever."

"Really? How?" Yuan quickly asked her.

"Well, if you want someone to stay with you, you propose to them, of course. It's common practice in this world."

"Propose? What do I propose to her?"

"That you want to stay with her forever, of course. However, you're still too inexperienced in this subject, so wait until you're a little older and more experienced before you actually propose to her, okay? Just don't make her wait too long, or she will be gone before you get the chance." Meifeng said to him.

Although she wanted to help her daughter and Yuan get together, she didn't want to take advantage of Yuan's innocence to do so, as it would only hurt their relationship in the future.

The only thing she can really do is help Yuan become aware of the situation and give him some advice. The rest will be up to him and Meixiu.

"I understand, Miss Meifeng. Thank you for the advice." Yuan said to her.

"I am merely doing my job as a mother, that's all," she said with a mysterious smile on her face.

After giving Yuan an hour-long massage, Meifeng closed the light and went to sleep.

"Let's do this again tomorrow. Goodnight, Young Master."

"Goodnight, Miss Meifeng," Yuan said, quickly falling asleep due to Meifeng's massage that had an immediate effect on his body.

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Chapter 501 Temporary

After falling asleep, Yuan returned to the realm of dreams once again, and the first thing he noticed was the handsome man from before, but he was sitting on a large boulder with a lonely expression on his face as he gazed at the drifting clouds.

When Yuan saw his expression, all thoughts of trying to disturb his peace disappeared, and Yuan patiently stood there.

"It feels great to finally start moving again, huh?" The handsome man suddenly spoke, his gaze still at the sky.

"Are you responsible for my sudden recovery?" Yuan asked him.

The handsome man turned to look at him and said, "Me? I am merely an imagination in your dreams. How could I possibly do that?"

"Even though you're strong?" Yuan said.

The handsome man laughed a little before speaking, "There are things even the strongest beings in the universe cannot achieve."

"If you're not responsible for my recovery, then who— or what is?"

"Who knows. Maybe you did it yourself by instinct. A cultivator is much more profound than you imagine."

"However, you shouldn't celebrate so early, as your body isn't completely healed."

"W-What? What do you mean? How do you know that?" Yuan had kind of expected this outcome when he heard Meifeng say the same thing, but this

handsome man appeared confident that he hasn't fully recovered yet.

"Because your body is still restricted by the curses. Your current freedom is merely temporary. If you don't continue to increase your cultivation, you will eventually return to your previous state." The handsome man said, leaving Yuan speechless.

A moment of silence later, Yuan said, "I want to increase my cultivation, but I am currently experiencing a bottleneck. I cannot breakthrough to Spirit Master no matter what. I think it's because there isn't enough spiritual energy in my place."

"Blaming on your environment for your lack of experience and failures? How typical of a weakling." The handsome man said with a cold smile on his face.

"There is sufficient spiritual energy in your world for you to breakthrough to Spirit Master. You just can't do it because you aren't capable."

"Then do you have any advice for me? The strong should help the weak out, right?"

The handsome man burst out laughing and said, "The strong should help the weak? Where did you hear that nonsense? In the cultivation world, you only have yourself. If someone decides to help you, it's mostly for their own benefit, or they have some other ulterior motives. You not only lack strength but you also lack common sense."

"Did the curses really screw with you that much? This is going to be troublesome." The man shook his head in a regretful manner.

"Forget it. Since you finally remember me, I will help you a little bit."

Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"But I don't remember you?"

"The fact that I am in your dream means you're starting to remember." The handsome man then suddenly snapped his fingers, changing the scenery.

"W-Where am I?" Yuan looked around his new environment that looked very familiar for some reason, and the handsome man had disappeared.

"Hey, it's that trash who can't breakthrough to Spirit Master while everyone else has long achieved it, *!\\#^!"

"You dare come out again after what happened last week? Are you looking for another beating, *!\\#^?"

Someone suddenly shouted, causing Yuan to turn around and look in that direction.

A few meters away, Yuan could see a group of young people wearing uniforms that looked very much like disciple uniforms.

'This looks like a sect... So this is the cultivation world? Why is he showing me this?' Yuan wondered to himself.

Then he noticed the young man that was standing not far away from this group of disciples.

Yuan's eyes widened with surprise when he saw this young man, as this young man had facial features that looked very much like him, and it made Yuan feel like he was watching himself.

However, this young man had a cold expression on his face that sent shivers down Yuan's back.

"Look! He's angry! Hahaha! What are you going to do, *!\\#^?! Beat us up?!"

"Hahaha!"

The group of disciples began laughing. These people were clearly bullies, and that young man whose name he couldn't hear for some reason was their victim.

"I have had enough of your bullshits! Every time we fight, you all gang up on me! Let's fight one on one if you dare!" The young man suddenly said in

a cold voice.

The group stopped laughing after hearing his words, and they exchanged glances with each other before nodding.

"Good. Then let's fight. However, I will only fight if it's in the Life or Death arena." One of the disciples stepped forward and spoke with an arrogant look on his face.

"Life or Death?" The young man frowned.

"What? Are you chickening out now? What happened to your brave words a moment ago?"

The young man sneered coldly and said, "Fine! If you want a Life or Death fight, then you got it!"

After the young man finished his sentence, the scenery changed again, and Yuan was standing before a large stage that was surrounded by disciples.

On the stage was the young man and the disciple that challenged him, both of them with weapons in their hands.

Once the match began, they both released their cultivation base.

The young man's cultivation was the peak of the Spirit Warrior, but his opponent was one level above him at the first level Spirit Master. However, the disparity from that one level was akin to heaven and earth.

"Aiya! To think *!\#^ would accept a Life or Death challenge from (*#@ \$%! He's courting death!"

While the spectators anticipated the young man's death, in the midst of the fierce battle, the young man suddenly had a breakthrough when he was on the verge of losing, entering the Spirit Master realm.

After his breakthrough, the young man instantly turned the tides and killed the other disciple in a gruesome manner.

Once the match ended, the scenery changed again, and the handsome man returned.

"What do you think?" The handsome man asked with a profound smile on his face.

"What am I supposed to think? Are you telling me to experience a life or death battle with someone in order to breakthrough?" Yuan said to him.

"You don't get it? Then watch it until you do." The handsome man snapped his fingers again, and Yuan returned to the arena right at the start of the life or death battle, watching them fight all over again.

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Chapter 502 Desperation

Once... twice... ten times...

Yuan watched the life or death fight between the young man and his opponent countless times.

'Just what am I looking for?'

Although Yuan didn't know what he was supposed to be looking at, he eventually just started focusing on the young man that had similar facial features as him.

After watching the young man countless times, Yuan noticed something hidden deep within the young man's eyes.

There was a certain light— a feeling of desperation, and this feeling only grew stronger the longer he was on the stage.

The desperation reached its peak when he was about to be killed.

That was when the young man suddenly experienced his breakthrough into Spirit Master.

"Are you telling me that I am not desperate enough?" Yuan spoke out loud.

Whoosh!

The handsome man returned with a smile on his face.

"That's precisely why. You are not desperate. If not for your condition, you would've not made it to Spirit Warrior, much less Spirit Master."

"Your world is quite peaceful compared to the cultivation world. Although there are some conflicts within the world, it usually doesn't affect you."

Yuan frowned and said, "Even if you say that, how am I supposed to become desperate? I can't feel what I don't feel."

"Then perhaps this will help you."

The handsome man waved his sleeves, giving him another scenario.

However, it wasn't of the life or death battle.

Instead, it was the scene of a family being slaughtered in broad daylight.

Yuan's eyes widened with shock as he witnessed a mother and her daughter — alongside thousands of pedestrians getting slaughtered mercilessly in the streets.

Although Yuan didn't recognize any of these people, tears began flowing from his eyes when he saw the woman and her daughter getting killed.

"Mother! Sister!"

A familiar voice suddenly resounded, causing Yuan to turn around.

Standing behind him was the same young man from the life or death battle, but he looked much younger... and weaker.

This young man was crying just like he was, but there was nothing he could do as he watched the murderer slaughter everyone there until a cultivator finally intervened to stop the madness.

Once the killer was apprehended, the young man walked to the corpses of the woman and the little girl.

He knelt on the ground with tears still flowing down his face and hugged their lifeless bodies until he was forced to let them go because the people had to clean the bodies off the streets.

Once their corpses were taken away, the young man stood up and turned to look at Yuan with a profound feeling of desperation in his gaze.

"This is my first experience with desperation. When will you experience your first? When your family dies before your eyes? When your loved ones are taken right before your very eyes? Or when you're betrayed by someone you trusted with your life?"

Yuan frowned and said, "I don't want to experience any of that."

"Of course you don't. Who would want to experience such misfortune?"

"However, you don't get to choose—the weak don't have any choice but to accept their fate."

"I can see pain in your eyes, but it's not desperation, so I will let you experience some more."

The young man turned around and walked away, and the scenery changed once again.

This time, the young man had his lover taken right in front of him, but he was too powerless to stop it.

Once that scene was over, another scene appeared, then another... and another...

Yuan experienced many different situations in his dream, all of them resulting in some sort of misfortune for the young man that increased his desperation for strength.

Eventually, the young man was no longer a weak young man but a handsome man with a formidable aura that stood at the peak of the cultivation world.

"Do you believe in reincarnation?" The handsome man suddenly asked Yuan as they returned to the sword graveyard.

"Reincarnation? As in rebirth?" Yuan asked, as he wasn't familiar with this term.

"Yes. In the cultivation world, people believe that you will be reincarnated after death, living a vastly different new life but without the memories of their previous lives, and that will repeat until you damage your soul."

"I don't know what to say. It's the cultivation world where anything could happen. As ridiculous as reincarnation sounds, I wouldn't be too surprised if it's real."

The handsome man smiled, and then he started approaching Yuan.

Once he stood before Yuan, the handsome man's appearance began turning younger and younger until he resembled the young man that resembled Yuan.

"You already know the truth deep inside, don't you? You just don't want to believe it." The young man said to him.

"I have no idea what you're talking about," Yuan said.

"Still trying to act dumb? Who do you think you're trying to fool? Me?"

"But that only means you're trying to fool yourself."

"..." Yuan turned dead silent as he stared at the young man who resembled him.

"You wanted to know who I am, right? Do I still need to answer that question?"

"Why?" Yuan suddenly asked.

"Why is this happening to me?"

"You should know that answer, too. If I tell you everything, it wouldn't be fun, right?"

"Or you actually don't know anything," Yuan said.

"You're right. I don't. After all, I am you, and you don't know anything. However, don't worry, because you will eventually remember..."

The young man's body suddenly started turning into smoke, disappearing into the background.

It was at this moment Yuan woke up from his dream, and he could immediately feel two streams of tears flowing down his face and the sensation of a wet pillow.

"Y-Young Master... Are you okay?" Meifeng, who woke up just a second ago, asked him in a worried voice after seeing his tears.

"Yes... I am fine. I just had a somewhat bad dream," he said with a bittersweet smile on his face.

"A nightmare, huh?" Meifeng then wiped his tears with her hands.

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Chapter 503 Playing the Piano

"Miss Meifeng... Have you ever felt desperation?" Yuan suddenly asked her after getting off the bed.

"Desperation?" Meifeng raised her eyebrows, wondering to herself why he would ask such a question.

"The feeling of being helpless— a sense of weakness and hopelessness." Yuan stood there with a profound aura around him that felt a little different than usual.

"I can't really say that I have..." Meifeng shook her head.

"However, the closest I have felt to desperation was when my husband died, I guess."

"Your husband?"

Now that he thought about it, Yuan has never seen Meixiu's father before.

"He died in an accident before I could even give birth to Meixiu," she said with a bittersweet smile on her face.

"I'm sorry for asking..."

"There's no need for you to be sorry. It happened really long ago." Meifeng said with a smile.

"Anyways, why the sudden question, Young Master? Does it have something to do with your nightmare?"

"I guess..." He nodded.

Sometime later, they sat around the living room and began eating breakfast.

"Wang Xiuying said that she's currently on the way here with the piano," said Meixiu after they sat down.

"This early in the morning?" Yuan chuckled.

"That just shows how much she wants to listen to your music again, Young Master," Meifeng said to him.

"Even if you say that, it's been years since I last touched an instrument... Not counting Cultivation Online, of course. I probably won't even be able to play it properly."

"You're underestimating yourself, Young Master. Even if you haven't touched any instruments in years, you'll quickly familiarize yourself with them once you start playing again."

"I hope so," he nodded.

After breakfast, while Meixiu cleaned the dishes and Yuan practiced his movement technique, Wang Xiuying arrived at their apartment door with her piano.

"Where should I put this?" Wang Xiuying asked.

"We have made some space in the living room. You can put it there." Meifeng said to her.

"Okay!"

The delivery company she hired to deliver the piano then placed the piano at the corner of the living room.

Once everything was done, Wang Xiuying immediately urged Yuan to play the piano.

"Don't worry, I won't break my promise..." Yuan said as he took a seat in front of the piano.

"Are you sure you want to give this piano away? It's quite rare and expensive." Meifeng recognized the piano's value at glance, and she asked Wang Xiuying.

"Yes, it is an honor for me to let Yu Tian play music using my piano. Furthermore, now that I am focused on cultivation, I don't have any time to play it. Instead of letting it rust in my room, I might as well give it to someone who can use it at its full potential."

After getting a feel for the smooth keys on the piano, Yuan swiped his fingers across the keyboard, filling the room with beautiful sounds.

'This feeling... How long has it been since I last felt it?' Yuan asked himself as he recalled one of his favorite songs.

Then, without using divine sense, Yuan began playing the piano almost instinctively.

Music quickly filled the place, and when the three ladies heard this heavenly music, their hearts throbbed with excitement.

Even though it's been years since Yuan last played the piano, he was currently playing it as though he never took a break. In other words, he was playing it flawlessly.

Tears flowed down Wang Xiuying's face as she stared at Yuan's figure that was moving elegantly behind the piano, recalling the first time she first witnessed his performance on the stage.

As for Meixiu and Meifeng, they could only silently admire Yuan's talents.

'This is it... This is the music that once took over the world. I can't believe that I am actually hearing it again, and it's not being played on a device.' Meifeng recalled Yuan's elegance and grace on the stage as he captivates the audiences' heart and soul with his musical talents.

A few minutes later, after playing the final note to the song, Yuan asked them, "What do you think? I think I could've played that a lot better."

"A lot better?" They all looked at him with raised eyebrows.

Meifeng then said, "I did notice a few delays between notes, but it's almost unrecognizable, and the delay is so minuscule that one wouldn't normally be able to tell the difference if they're not an expert."

"I guess I am just used to playing it to perfection. Let me try another song."

Yuan then began playing a new song, and it somehow sounded even better than the last, something Wang Xiuying didn't think was possible until it happened.

After his second song, Yuan continued to play a few more songs, getting better with each song until he eventually reached the perfection that he was used to.

Ding.

In the midst of Yuan's 9th song, Meixiu suddenly received a notification on her phone.

She looked at it to see that Yu Rou had texted her.

Her eyes widened when she read the contents.

"Y-Yu Rou is coming here right now!" Meixiu said to them.

Yuan immediately stopped playing the piano and said, "Yu Rou is coming here? Why?"

"She said that she needed to talk to me. Also, she said that she received her parents' permission."

Hearing this, Meifeng said, "The Yu Family probably told Yu Rou to come to convince you to return to the family after the last failure. They're really predictable."

"What should we do now, Young Master?"

Yuan then pondered for a moment before speaking, "I have been thinking about how I should surprise Yu Rou regarding my recovery..."

He touched the piano and said, "I think I know how I should surprise her. Can you all help me out?"

"Of course!" Wang Xiuying quickly said.

Meixiu and Meifeng also agreed.

"Great! Then here's the plan..."

After telling them his plan to surprise Yu Rou, Yuan returned to his bedroom and patiently waited for Yu Rou to arrive.

Half an hour later, someone knocked on their door.

"It's me!" Yu Rou's voice then resounded.

As they had expected, it was Yu Rou.

However, Yu Rou was completely unaware of the surprise that was in store for her.

Chapter 504 Surprising Yu Rou

"Good morning, Meixiu!" Yu Rou greeted when she opened the door.

"Good morning, Yu Rou." Meixiu returned the greeting.

"Please, come inside."

Once Yu Rou entered their apartment, she immediately noticed Meifeng and Wang Xiuying sitting in the living room.

"Eh? Miss Meifeng? Wang Xiuying? What are you two doing here so early in the morning?" Yu Rou asked them with a surprised look on her face.

"I'm on vacation, so I figured I should visit the Young Master," Meifeng said with a calm look on her face.

"I am here to check up on Yu Tian's condition," said Wang Xiuying.

Although she wasn't sure why, Yu Rou felt that something was amiss from the atmosphere in the place.

"I see... Where's my brother? I'd like to see him before I talk... though I'm sure you can already guess why I am here."

"The Young Master is currently in his room," Meifeng said.

Yu Rou nodded and approached his room, but then she noticed the beautiful piano sitting at the corner of the room and stopped to look at it.

"Wow! What is this premium piano doing here? It wasn't here when I last came here."

As a piano player herself, Yu Rou could instantly tell that the piano was a valuable one.

"That piano is mine... At least it was until I gave it to Yu Tian," said Wang Xiuying.

"Eh? It's yours? But why?" Yu Rou asked.

"I have no use for it anymore, and I'd rather give it to my idol than sell it."

Yu Rou found it strange that she would give it to Yuan when he can't even use it, and in her eyes, it was quite disrespectful to give an instrument to Yuan while knowing his background and condition. It was almost like giving a blind man a book that he cannot read.

Though Yu Rou didn't think too much of it for now.

"Brother, it's Yu Rou. I am here to visit you," she said to him after knocking on the doors.

"Come inside," Yuan said.

Yu Rou then entered the room and sat beside the bed.

"Even though we have been playing together in Cultivation Online for a while, it still feels like forever since I last saw you..." Yu Rou gently caressed his silky black hair to the side so she could get a good look at his handsome face.

"I'm sorry, brother..."

"Why are you suddenly apologizing?" Yuan asked her.

"Because of the Yu Family, both you and Meixiu have been experiencing unpleasant situations. I wish I could help, but I am powerless within the family..."

"There's no need for you to apologize, Yu Rou. If anything, it should be the ones responsible that need to apologize. This means the Chairman of the

Cultivators' Association and our parents."

"..."

After a moment of silence, Yu Rou spoke, "Brother, I am thinking about leaving the family and joining a faction."

"Huh? W-Why would you do that?" Yuan was taken by surprise by her sudden reveal.

"Now that cultivation is widespread and the new trend, I want to take advantage of it, especially since I am currently ahead of many people. If I remain in the Yu Family, I will forever remain powerless. However, if I leave, I will at least have a chance to become an influential person without the help of my family."

"It's not going to be easy, but I hope to become stronger than the Yu Family."

Yuan was speechless after listening to Yu Rou's plans.

However, he didn't immediately dismiss it, and he asked, "Where will you go?"

"I don't know right now, but I can tell you where I won't go—the Cultivators' Association! They're just a bunch of bullies, and I refuse to lend them my assistance. I already have a Heaven-grade cultivation technique thanks to my family, so I don't really care where I go as long as they're good people with enough influence to not be bullied by the Yu Family."

"I see... When you decide, let me know, okay?"

"Of course!"

"Anyways, I am here today because my parents wanted me to convince Meixiu to return to the family so that they could hand her over to the Cultivators' Association. I agreed since it meant that I would get to see you and Meixiu again, but I won't be doing any convincing."

"I'm sorry to get you wrapped up in this mess as well... But don't worry, I will handle everything soon."

"You will? What are you going to do?" Yu Rou couldn't help but ask.

"It's a secret for now," he said with a mysterious smile.

"I hope it's not anything dangerous..." Yu Rou said with a worried frown.

"It won't be." Yuan chuckled.

Sometime later, Yuan said, "Yu Rou, you saw the piano, right? Why don't you let Meixiu play you a song?"

"Eh? Meixiu knows how to play the piano? Since when?"

"She's been practicing lately, you see."

"If you say so..."

Yu Rou then went back outside and said, "Meixiu, my brother said you'll play a song for me?"

Meixiu nodded, "But you'll have to wear this."

Yu Rou looked at the object in Meixiu's hand; it was a blindfold.

"Why do I have to be blindfolded? I won't be able to see your performance that way."

"I want you to judge it using your ears, not eyes," Meixiu then said.

"I guess so..."

Once Yu Rou took a seat on the couch, Meixiu blindfolded her.

A few moments later, Yu Rou could hear the piano being played.

'Wow... Meixiu is really good with the piano... How long has she been practicing to reach this level?' Yu Rou wasn't suspicious at first, but once she listened a little longer, she noticed something was off, and the feeling she got earlier grew more obvious.

'T-This can't be Meixiu playing the piano... It's too good! Even I cannot play this perfectly with many years of practice! Unless Meixiu has talents similar to my brother, there's no way she learned the piano and reached this level in such a short amount of time!'

Although she didn't want to discredit Meixiu or her talents, it was simply too hard to believe. It hasn't been long since Meixiu left the Yu Family, and even if she started playing the day she left, it wasn't realistic for Meixiu to reach this level of performance in such a short time unless she was Yuan himself!

'Maybe this is Miss Meifeng playing the piano and they wanted to play a trick on me...'

Yu Rou began having this thought.

Midway through the song, someone suddenly removed her blindfold, causing it to fall onto her lap.

"Hmm?"

Yu Rou subconsciously opened her eyes when she felt the blindfold fall off, and to her absolute shock, it wasn't Meixiu sitting in front of the piano, nor was it Meifeng like she'd thought.

It was actually Yuan sitting before the piano! And he was playing with elegance and grace!

"B-Brother...?" Yu Rou stood up from the shock, and she stared at Yuan's moving figure with a look of disbelief on her face.

However, she didn't say anything else and silently watched Yuan play the piano with a seemingly healthy and normal body, feeling as though she was

in a dream.

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Chapter 505 His Own Company

After playing the last note to the song, Yuan lifted his hands from the piano keyboard in an elegant manner before turning to face the shocked Yu Rou with a smile on his face.

"What do you think? I may not be as good as I used to be, but I hope you enjoyed it."

Hearing his words, Yu Rou's eyes finally started flowing with tears, and because she'd held it in for so long, it came gushing forward like a broken dam, immediately blocking her vision.

"Brother... You're so cruel..." Yu Rou said in a crying voice, dumbfounding him.

And she continued, "How can you make me cry in front of so many people...?"

Yu Rou then wiped her tears and said, "How come you can move again? And since when?"

Yuan then explained to her that he has no clue why it happened, "I woke up like this, and it has only been like 2 days since my recovery."

"It's only been two days...? And your recovery happened out of the blue? What kind of miracle is this?" Yu Rou was left speechless by his words.

Thousands of doctors around the world couldn't figure out what was going on with Yuan's condition, and he somehow heals naturally? That seemed too good to be true. However, there was no reason for Yuan to lie to her.

Yuan suddenly approached Yu Rou and wiped the tears from her face.

"To tell you the truth, my recovery actually started even before I left the Yu Family, but I was only able to lift a finger at that time, and I didn't want to get your hopes up, so I decided to wait until I could stand on my own before letting you know."

"Unbelievable..." Yu Rou muttered in a low voice.

After a moment of silence, she said, "This changes everything, brother! Now that you have recovered, there are so many things you can do! What do you plan on doing now that you have recovered?"

"I am going to focus on rehabilitation for now. Once I am confident with my movements, I am going to visit the Cultivators' Association. However, I am not sure what I want to do after that."

"Do you intend on going back to the stage?" Yu Rou asked the question that has been asked multiple times now.

"No, I do not." Yuan shook his head.

Yu Rou sighed and said, "I figured... But you should reconsider, since it's such a waste of your talents. Brother, you never truly reached the peak of the musical world since you were forced to leave it due to your condition, and it has always been a dream of mine to see you on the stage again. Furthermore, you can get back at the Yu Family for abandoning you."

"If you return to the stage, they will definitely regret disowning you. In fact, they might even try to get you back into the family."

"Hmm..." Yuan didn't immediately refuse and began pondering.

'Getting back at the Yu Family, huh? I definitely want to see their faces filled with regret. However, I shouldn't be doing this for revenge... Instead, I should be doing this for Yu Rou, who has been there for me since the beginning.'

'If Yu Rou wants me to return to the stage...'

Although he has already decided to never return to the professional stage, he also told himself that he would do anything to make Yu Rou happy, and if him returning to the stage will make her happy, he cannot simply ignore it.

"Brother, if you don't want to return to the stage, I won't force you." Yu Rou said to him, as she could guess what he was thinking.

"I..."

It was at this moment Meifeng spoke, "Young Master, if I may make a suggestion, you don't need to go onto the stage as 'Yu Tian'. You can simply do it under a different alias. After all, it's not the stage you hate—but your name that is affiliated with the Yu Family, am I right?"

"I have listened closely to all of your performances today, and I can tell that you still enjoy playing the instrument. You're afraid that if you go onto the stage that you'll once again give credit to the Yu Family."

"If I am wrong, please correct me."

Yuan remained silent for a moment before speaking, "I have known that I still love to play the instrument when I played the zither inside Cultivation Online. I think you're right, Miss Meifeng. It's not the stage that I don't like—I just don't want to feel like I am being used by the Yu Family again."

"Brother..." Yu Rou felt incredibly guilty at this moment, as she was part of the Yu Family that made Yuan feel so much pain and grief.

"Well, there are many things you can do to avoid that feeling, such as playing for another company. Or even better—you can make your own company so that you won't be playing for anyone but yourself."

"Making my own company? As much as I like the sound of that, I am only 18 years old... How am I supposed to make a company?"

Meifeng lifted her hand and pointed it at herself.

"You don't need to do anything, Young Master. I can make the company for you."

"R-Really? But aren't you already incredibly busy at the Yu Family? I don't dare to make you work even more than you already are..." Yuan said.

"It's really not that much work. Although I will be making the company, I won't actually need to do anything, and when I do, I can do it from anywhere in the world as long as I have access to a phone and the internet."

"Furthermore, you can hire other people to deal with the stuff. In fact, Meixiu has some experience when it comes to these kinds of things since this is what we mainly do for the Yu Family."

Meifeng then turned to look at Meixiu and continued, "I will make the company and you'll do everything else. Since it's just a company in name, you don't actually have to do much besides organizing events for the Young Master. You should be able to do at least that with your training. If you need help, I will step in. What do you think?"

Chapter 506 - Divine Melody

"I don't mind as long as Yu Tian agrees," Meixiu said in a calm voice after hearing Meifeng's suggestion.

Besides maid training and defensive training, Meixiu also learned management since she was expected to help Yuan with his work in the future just like how Meifeng helps the Yu Family.

"It's all up to you now, Young Master. As long as you give me a nod, I will make the company."

Yuan didn't immediately respond and took a couple of minutes to think about everything.

Although he didn't care about getting revenge on the Yu Family for what they have done to him, he definitely would like to see their faces once they learn that he has recovered and started playing on the stage again.

Furthermore, he will be making Yu Rou happy by doing so.

Sometime later, Yuan nodded and said, "I will leave everything to you, Miss Meifeng."

"Great! Now I just need the name of the company and what your new alias will be!" Meifeng said, her voice filled with enthusiasm, as this could be the start of a new legend.

"A company name, huh? Do you guys have any suggestions?" Yuan asked the ladies in the room.

"How about Divine Melody? Your music is always divine-sounding, after all." Wang Xiuying was the first to give a suggestion.

"Divine Melody, huh? I also quite like it." Yu Rou agreed.

"Well, if you both like it, I guess we'll go with Divine Melody. As for my new alias..."

Yuan pondered for a moment before speaking, "Tian Yang shall be my new alias."

"Okay. I will make a few phone calls with a few friends and I should have the company ready by tonight." Meifeng said as she pulled out her phone and walked outside the apartment.

"I cannot wait! This is so exciting!" Yu Rou spoke with her body trembling from excitement.

"I can already imagine my parents trying to recruit you once they learn of your existence!"

"I am also shaking from excitement!" Wang Xiuying agreed.

"Let's not get ahead of ourselves." Yuan said, and he continued, "I may be under a new alias, but if I go outside in my current appearance, they will learn my real identity in a heartbeat."

"I will need a disguise..."

"How about wearing a mask like you do in Cultivation Online?" Meixiu suggested.

"Yes, I was thinking the same thing," he agreed.

Meixiu went to grab her laptop and started looking for a mask.

"Which one do you like?" Meixiu asked him.

Yuan then pointed to the black mask that somewhat resembled the one in Cultivation Online.

"I like this one," he said.

Yu Rou raised her eyebrows when she saw this, and she asked, "Brother... How do you see with your eyes closed?"

"Hm? Oh, I am using divine sense to see. My sight hasn't healed yet."

"D-Divine sense?! You can also use that in the real world?!" Yu Rou was shocked.

"Yes." He nodded.

"Now I'm really curious what else can be used in the real world besides cultivation techniques and divine sense..." Yu Rou mumbled.

"Well, for one, other techniques besides cultivation techniques also work," Yuan said.

"Huh? Have you succeeded in learning a martial technique?" Yu Rou asked him, as she had this feeling.

"Yes, I have. I am now trying to learn a movement technique."

"C-Can I see the technique you learned?!" Yu Rou quickly asked.

"Sure."

Yuan then used his divine sense to look for a knife. Once he found it, he made it fly towards them from the kitchen.

"T-This is your Flying Dagger technique!" Yu Rou recognized this technique since she has seen him use it a couple of times during their questing.

"That's right." Yuan nodded.

"Heavens... That looks incredibly dangerous..." Wang Xiuying mumbled as she watched the kitchen knife circle around Yuan's body.

"Should I start trying to learn Wind Blade?" Yu Rou wondered to herself out loud.

"That sounds even more dangerous..." Yuan said, as he could somehow imagine Yu Rou causing mass destruction with Wind Blades.

"I have ordered the mask. It should arrive within the next three days." Meixiu said a moment later.

Sometime later, Meifeng returned and said, "I have the company set up. I will be the owner of the company in name, but I will leave everything to you, Meixiu. Once you settle your situation with the Cultivators' Association and decide to reveal your identity, I will transfer the company to you. And in case you need some refreshments, I will send you the training notes from years prior."

"I understand." Meixiu nodded.

"As for the Young Master, you just need to schedule a performance and start making a name for yourself again. I suggest you do a couple of public performances to gain popularity before you return to the stage."

"Okay."

And for the rest of the day, Yuan would play the piano for the ladies in the apartment. During breaks, they would talk about their new company and plan for their future.

At the end of the day, Yu Rou said, "I would love to stay here for longer, but it's about time I return home and report to my parents that I have failed to convince Meixiu to return to the family. I expect a scolding, but it is what it is."

"I'm sorry, Yu Rou... This is all because of me..."

"Don't blame yourself for this situation, Meixiu. We all know who's in the wrong here." Yu Rou patted her back.

"Yu Rou, before you leave."

Yuan approached her with his arms spread, his intentions clear.

Seeing this, Yu Rou immediately jumped into his embrace and hugged him tightly.

"I have been waiting for this for the entire day, you idiot." Yu Rou said, feeling her eyes tear up again.

"I'm sorry for making you wait so long."

Once they were satisfied, Yuan let her go and Yu Rou made her way back to the Yu Family.

"I am also going to leave as well. It's been a fun day. I will be coming here often to hear your music, Yu Tian!" Wang Xiuying said shortly after Yu Rou left.

Yuan nodded and said, "Once again, thank you for the piano. I will treasure it."

"That means more than you think to me.." Wang Xiuying said with a bright smile on her face.

Chapter 507 - Breaking His Bottleneck

After Wang Xiuying left, Meixiu began cooking dinner while Meifeng looked over some documents for their newly created company.

"Young Master, you'll need a disguise for your new alias," Meifeng said to him, unaware that they already have something planned.

"Yes, I know. I will be wearing a mask when I play on the stage," he said.

"A mask, huh? That's not a bad idea." Meifeng agreed.

Sometime later, after dinner, Yuan went to take a shower. Now that he can clean himself, he plans on doing so every single day.

Once it was time for sleep, Meifeng and Yuan retired to their room while Meixiu returned to her own room.

"Miss Meifeng, I have a question..." Yuan suddenly asked her as they laid in the same bed.

"What is it?"

"Do you know where I can obtain a sword?"

"A-A sword? Like a real sword? Why do you want one?"

"Self-defense, I guess..."

"Self-defense?" Meifeng looked at him with raised eyebrows.

What kind of self-defense requires a sword?

"You see, the world is getting more dangerous lately with more and more people becoming cultivators, obtaining inhuman strength that's only possible in the cultivation world, but our world is very small compared to the world in Cultivation Online, and I was worried about what might happen in the future, so I want to prepare myself."

"Cultivators may be strong, but I don't think we have to be that worried. It's not as though the world will suddenly become a lawless place. But since the Young Masters want a sword, I will try to do something about it."

"Thank you."

Meifeng fell asleep shortly afterward.

However, Yuan didn't go to sleep.

Instead, he silently got out of the bed and went to the living room, before taking a seat on the floor.

'This will be my first time cultivating in this position...' Yuan thought to himself as he started to absorb the spiritual energy in the air.

'Desperation... I am not desperate enough to reach Spirit Master?' He recalled what the handsome man told him in his dreams.

Yuan then remembered the scenes where the mother and her daughter were murdered in broad daylight. Then he recalled the betrayal of a friend. Then of the young man's lover being forcefully taken away.

After remembering these situations, Yuan subconsciously started replacing these individuals with people he knew.

He imagined Meifeng and Yu Rou getting killed before his eyes. He imagined being betrayed by Doctor Wang and Wang Xiuying. He imagined the Cultivators' Association successfully taking Meixiu away from him by force.

"You're so weak... How can you protect anyone like that?"

The handsome man's voice suddenly resounded in his head.

Yuan gritted his teeth, and somewhere within his consciousness, an invisible flame created by desperation appeared.

The spiritual energy in the area began flying towards Yuan at an incredibly fast rate.

"That's right. If you want to protect those you care about, you must be strong."

"Obtain the strength to protect your family and friends..."

"Obtain the power to defeat those who wish to covet from you..."

"Be desperate... desperate for power..."

The handsome man's voice continued to resound inside Yuan's head as he subconsciously cultivated, and before he was aware, he entered a trance-like state—he'd entered enlightenment.

Meixiu, who was just about to fall asleep, noticed the sudden change in the atmosphere.

She got out of the bed and looked peeked outside her room, and to her surprise, there was a figure sitting in the living room with his long black hair fluttering behind him like a cape before a gust of wind.

'Yuan...?' Meixiu mumbled to herself.

Even though she was clearly looking at Yuan, for some reason, it felt like she wasn't looking at Yuan at the same time, almost like she was looking at someone else and the Yuan there was merely an illusion.

Meanwhile, Yuan's cultivation that had been stuck at peak Spirit Warrior finally began to move.

His Dantian that contained all of his spiritual energy began to tremble, and it slowly began expanding in size.

Then, the golden symbol within his body that had turned into veins attached itself to the Dantian, turning it golden.

Yuan's body was currently emitting a faint golden glow, and Meixiu was there to witness it, feeling as though she was before a divine being.

Meixiu didn't want to disturb him, so she went back inside her room and returned to the bed, trying her best to fall asleep.

The following morning, Yuan stood up from the floor with a profound feeling in his body.

He was no longer a Spirit Warrior, and his body emitted the feeling of a Spirit Master.

'So this is what it feels like to be a Spirit Master in this world...'

Yuan took a deep breath, sucking in a large amount of spiritual energy.

"Good morning, Meixiu." Yuan suddenly noticed her presence and said to her.

"Did you breakthrough to Spirit Master? You feel a little different compared to yesterday." Meixiu asked him.

"Yes, I have managed to breakthrough my bottleneck." He nodded.

"How do you feel?"

"My divine sense is much stronger now, and I can keep it active for a lot longer. I haven't tried using Flying Daggers, but it should be easier to control the technique now," he said.

He then tried to use Flying Daggers, and to his surprise, he was able to control 3 kitchen knives at once with relative ease when he could barely control two before.

"Wow... The difference between Spirit Warrior and Spirit Master is so much even though it was only a single level..." Yuan was surprised by the results.

"Congratulations on reaching Spirit Master."

Yuan nodded, "Yes, now I can finally visit the Cultivators' Association."

"You're really going to do it?" Meixiu asked in a worried voice.

He smiled and said, "How else am I going to stop them from taking you away from me?"

Meixiu blushed at his words.

"I-I am going to prepare breakfast..." she said, making a quick escape.

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Chapter 508 - I Will Come With You

"Good morning, Young Master. You're up earlier than usual today," Meifeng said to him after coming out of his room.

"I actually spent the night cultivating," he said with a smile.

"I see..."

After eating breakfast, Yuan would spend about two hours just playing the piano without any rest.

Afterward, he would continue practicing the movement technique.

Meanwhile, Yu Rou stood before her parents.

"How did it go?" Yu Yong asked her.

"It failed. Meixiu refused to return even when I asked." Yu Rou said.

"Che!" Tang Lee sneered in disgust.

"Meixiu appeared to be enjoying her current life with Yu Tian. I think it'd be for the better if we didn't disturb their new life." Yu Rou said.

"I have a feeling that you didn't even bother to convince her. Tell me, Yu Rou, what exactly did you do yesterday when you spent an entire day at their place?" Yu Yong asked her in a solemn voice.

"I tried to convince Meixiu to return to the family, but when it failed, I remained there to hang out with them since it's been a while." Yu Rou said

in a casual voice.

And before her parents could speak, she continued, "I don't know why you want Meixiu back so desperately, but even if she used to serve me, remember that Meixiu was trained to serve Yu Tian. My brother was the reason that Meixiu even wanted to be a maid in the first place, so if you're thinking about tearing them apart, it won't happen."

"Hmph! Leave! And you're still forbidden to contact that trash since you didn't get any satisfactory results!" Tang Lee said to her.

Yu Rou frowned, but she didn't say anything and left the place.

"Looks like we'll have to rely on the mercenaries. Chairman Zhao has been getting more impatient as well." Yu Yong sighed.

He then retrieved his cellphone to give Mister Johnson a call.

Three days passed by in a flash, and someone knocked on Yuan's apartment early in the morning.

"Delivery!"

Meixiu went to open the door since she was expecting this package.

"Thank you."

After accepting the package, Meixiu went to the living room and called out to Yuan, "Yu Tian, your masks have arrived."

A few moments later, Yuan came out of the bathroom.

"Great. Let's see what we have."

After opening the package, Yuan could see over a dozen different masks in the package.

"Hmm? Did they give us more than we ordered by accident? I don't remember picking most of these." Yuan said.

"Oh, I forgot to mention it but I decided to buy a few more afterward just in case we needed it. I even picked a new design for some of them if you ever get bored of one." Meixiu said.

"I see, that makes sense. Thanks."

Yuan picked one randomly and wore it on his face.

"What do you think?" He asked them.

"You give off a mysterious feeling. I like it, Young Master." Meifeng gave her opinion.

"I think it looks good, too." Meixiu nodded calmly, as she was already used to seeing him wear masks in Cultivation Online.

"Great. Then I will be wearing one of these while I visit the Cultivators' Association tomorrow."

"You're really planning on going there? It's going to be dangerous..." Meifeng said.

"If I don't go, they will continue messing with Meixiu, and I am not going to sit around and let it happen. Now that I am no longer useless, I am going to do something useful with my body for once." Yuan said with a stern look on his face.

"..."

After a moment of silence, Meifeng said, "If you're going, then I will go with you."

"Eh? You will? But won't you cause trouble for the Yu Family?" Yuan said.

Meifeng then picked up one of the available masks and wore it on her face.

"I won't cause any trouble if they don't know who I am," she chuckled.

"Furthermore, you'll need some backup just in case anything happens."

"What about—"

"You stay here." Meifeng interrupted Meixiu before she could even finish speaking.

"Don't worry, I will be more than enough to guarantee the Young Master's safety."

"I understand..." Meixiu said, clearly discontent with the results, but she didn't want to argue with her mother, and since she's wanted by the Cultivators' Association, it would be better if she didn't go to their main headquarters.

That night, Yuan went to sleep to make sure he was in top condition for tomorrow.

"Looks like you're finally going to do something about the situation."

The handsome man appeared in his dreams again.

"You again?" Yuan sighed.

Ever since he'd started walking, he would have to deal with this handsome man who's supposedly him before his reincarnation every time he went to sleep.

"Why are you not happy to see me? This means that you're slowly recovering your memories."

"What if I don't want these memories?" Yuan said with a frown.

"You don't want to remember? Even though it'll make you stronger? Are you afraid that you might become a different person once you remember everything?" The handsome man asked Yuan even though he already knew the answer.

"Everybody will change if given enough time. This is not something you can prevent no matter how powerful you are. However, you are in control of what kind of person you want to be, so why are you afraid?"

"I am not afraid," Yuan said in a calm voice.

And he continued, "I just don't want to experience unnecessary emotions that you—I felt before. What happened in the past happened in the past. I don't need to know about it."

The handsome man smiled and said, "If you don't care about what happened in the past, you wouldn't exist right now."

"What do you mean by that?" Yuan frowned slightly.

"You exist for a reason—reincarnated for a reason. You may not understand it now, but you will eventually remember everything and understand your reason for existing."

The handsome man then looked towards the sky and said, "It's about time for you to wake up. I look forward to what you're going to do today. Perhaps you've already started changing—you just don't realize it."

After that sentence ended, Yuan woke up from his sleep.

Chapter 509 - I Am Here To Speak With Your Chairman

"Good morning, Meixiu." Yuan greeted her, who was already preparing breakfast.

"Morning."

Once breakfast was prepared, they sat around the dining table until all of the plates were empty.

"Once we deal with the Cultivators' Association, let's go out and eat at a restaurant, Meixiu," Yuan said to her afterward.

"O-Okay..." Although it was quite sudden, Meixiu agreed regardless.

After breakfast, Yuan changed into a new set of clothes and grabbed his mask.

"Are you ready, Miss Meifeng?" Yuan asked her, who was right behind him.

"Wait a second, Young Master," Meifeng said.

And she continued, "The Yu Family was able to find your location because they'd somehow managed to acquire footage of you and Meixiu on the public surveillance cameras, so I would advise you to take a different route — one that is hidden from these cameras."

"How am I supposed to know where to go?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"Don't worry, I have already found a route from this place to the Cultivators' Association that will allow us to travel without being seen. You

just need to follow me."

"Okay, I will leave everything to you. I want to save my spiritual energy for when I reach the Cultivators' Association, so can I hold your hands until then?" Yuan then asked her.

Since he needed spiritual energy for divine sense, it would be wiser to save his spiritual energy until he needed it. And even though he can use his divine sense for much longer now that he's a Spirit Master, it still wasn't enough for him to keep it activated for long periods at a time.

"Of course, you can." Meifeng held her hands out with a smile on her beautiful face.

Yuan then wore his mask before grabbing her soft hands.

Meifeng also wore her mask before leading Yuan outside the door and into the streets, following the route Meifeng had prepared in advance to avoid being seen.

"It will take us a little longer to reach the Cultivators' Association since we're taking this unique route. Since we have some time, can you tell me what you intend on doing there so I can prepare for it?" Meifeng asked him as they walked hand in hand.

"I am going there to intimidate them," he responded in a calm voice.

"Excuse me?" Meifeng turned to look at him with her eyes filled with shock.

"You're going to intimidate the Cultivators' Association? One of the most powerful factions in the entire world right now? You know even the Yu Family don't dare to offend them, right?" She said to him in a dazed voice.

"Yes, I know," Yuan responded in a calm voice.

"Then how are you going to intimidate them?"

"If words won't get through them, I can only use force, right?" Yuan said.

"F-Force...?" Meifeng had a bad feeling about this, and she started regretting agreeing to this farce.

"Don't worry, I am confident in my strength."

"I am not worried about that... But if you act violently at the Cultivators' Association, you will get arrested."

"The Cultivators' Association is not only a powerful force, but they are also something like the police for cultivators since normal police won't be able to deal with cultivators and their incredible strength."

"Simply, you'll go to jail that is specifically made for cultivators."

"I won't do anything violent... if I don't have to."

Meifeng sighed and mumbled to herself, 'Looks like I might have to call some lawyers after this all goes down...'

Meifeng wasn't too worried that Yuan might go to jail for causing a scene in the Cultivators' Association as long as he doesn't kill anyone, as she has connections with many powerful and reliable lawyers who can get someone out of anything as long as they had enough money.

About an hour later, they arrive at the Cultivators' Association.

"We're here, Young Master. Please... Just don't do anything too crazy..." Meifeng pleaded.

Yuan didn't say anything and merely nodded.

He then stood there for a minute to prepare himself.

Once he was ready, he released Meifeng's hand and began walking towards the Cultivators' Association, and Meifeng followed him from behind.

Their unique appearance quickly attracted everyone's attention, and they wondered why Yuan and Meifeng were wearing masks.

There was a line to the reception, but Yuan ignored the line and walked straight to the front.

"The line is back there." The woman working at the reception pointed to the back of the line.

"I am here to speak with your Chairman. Take me to him."

"I'm sorry, but who are you?"

"I will only speak with the chairman."

"I'm afraid that's not possible. Until we know your identity, you won't see anyone. Furthermore, Chairman Zhao is currently busy in a meeting, so he won't have time for you—"

BANG!

Yuan suddenly slammed the desk with his fist, instantly destroying it.

This startled the woman and everyone there greatly, including Meifeng, who felt like she was suddenly before a different person.

"I will not repeat myself," Yuan said in a calm voice that had a hint of anger within.

The woman looked at the destroyed desk with her eyes wide with shock, as the desk was made out of metal and not something an ordinary cultivator could achieve.

A few moments later, once the guards there snapped out of their daze, they quickly surrounded Yuan and Meifeng.

"Who the hell do you think you are?! How dare you cause such a scene at the Cultivators' Association?!"

The head of the security there shouted at Yuan. Of course, they were all cultivators.

Yuan slowly turned his head to look at the middle-aged man who was at the 6th level Spirit Apprentice.

"If you bring me to your chairman, there will no longer be a scene," he then said.

"The audacity! Apprehend them!" The middle-aged man commanded the dozen of cultivators around him.

However, before they could even get close, Yuan released his Spirit Master cultivation base, instantly halting these Spirit Apprentices with intense pressure.

Although none of them could comprehend what they were feeling since they had never seen a Spirit Master before, they instinctively knew to stay away from Yuan or their lives would be in danger.

Chapter 510 - The Presence Of A Spirit Master

Badum! Badum! Badum!

The cultivators around Yuan could feel their hearts being squeezed by this invisible pressure the longer they remained around him, so they all took steps back, fearing that their hearts might be crushed if they continued going forward.

"W-Who are you?! Why do you want to speak with the chairman?! If you do anything funny, the entire Cultivators' Association will be upon you!" The head guard pointed at Yuan and shouted.

"..."

After a moment of silence, Yuan spoke, "Yuan. Tell your chairman that Yuan is here to see him."

"Y-Yuan...? D-Don't tell me that you're 'that' Yuan from Cultivation Online...?" The head guard was left speechless by this revelation.

The others were also shocked by Player Yuan's sudden appearance.

As for as they were aware, the real Player Yuan has never appeared in public before, and judging by his appearance and unfathomable presence, there was a good chance that this masked figure before them was truly Player Yuan—the number one mysterious player in Cultivation Online!

Meanwhile, somewhere on the top floor of the Cultivators' Association, a decently sized group of individuals with ages ranging from old to young sat

around a large conference table with Chairman Zhao sitting at the end, and all of them were emitting a profound aura.

"If your exalted families join our Cultivators' Association that is currently the number one force in the world, it will permanently stabilize our position in the world, and your families will definitely be compensated greatly for it." Chairman Zhao said to these individuals.

However, before any of these people could even respond, they felt an unfathomable pressure appearing right beneath them, shocking them greatly.

"H-Heavens! What was that?! Who is releasing this pressure?!"

"This pressure... It's the presence of a Spirit Master!"

"Impossible!"

The old people there stood up from shock after feeling the pressure.

"What? Did you just say Spirit Master? Is that even possible?" Chairman Zhao exclaimed in a dumbfounded voice.

His phone began ringing the very next moment.

"What happened? Don't you know that I am currently in a meeting with the grand families?"

"C-Chairman Zhao! I deeply apologize for disturbing your meeting with the seniors, but we have an emergency! Someone claiming to be 'Yuan' is here to see you! And he's causing a commotion!"

"What? Yuan? Why does that name sound so familiar?" Chairman Zhao muttered out loud, causing everyone there to look at him.

Then he came to a realization.

"Y-Yuan?! That Player Yuan from Cultivation Online?! Is it really him?!" Chairman Zhao shouted at the phone.

"I-I think so! He's even wearing a mask to conceal his identity! I think he's real!"

"Tell him to stay put! I will be there in a moment!" Chairman Zhao closed the connection and turned to look at the people there with an apologetic smile.

"I am coming with you. I would like to see if this person is really that famous 'Player Yuan'." One of the old men there spoke.

"I am also curious."

Eventually, everyone in the room agreed to follow Chairman Zhao.

'Is it really Player Yuan? Why would he show up so suddenly? And what business does he have with me?' Chairman Zhao wondered to himself as he walked to the elevators with the others, as he doesn't recall having any contact with Yuan before.

Sometime later, they arrived downstairs, and they could see two individuals wearing a mask being surrounded by many people there.

"A-Are you really Player Yuan?!" One of the people gathered around them asked.

However, Yuan ignored him and continued to stand there in silence.

The old people following Chairman Zhao took a deep breath as they approached the masked man who was emitting a profound pressure.

'Spirit Master! He's really a Spirit Master!'

They were quite shocked to see an unknown Spirit Master.

"Make way! The Chairman is here!"

The head guard shouted at the people there.

A path quickly opened up, allowing Chairman Zhao to approach Yuan, but he didn't get too close, as he had a bad feeling about this situation.

"Are you really Player Yuan? Why do you want to speak with me?"

Yuan didn't say anything at first and started slowly walking towards Chairman Zhao until he was standing right before him.

"I am here to give you a warning today. If you dare try to lay a finger on Meixiu again, I will destroy the entire Cultivators' Association." Yuan spoke in a grim voice with his pressure growing stronger and stronger.

Chairman Zhao could feel an invisible hand crushing his heart from the pressure, but he gritted his teeth and endured it.

"M-Meixiu...? How are you related to her?" Chairman Zhao asked him with a deep frown as he was having trouble breathing, and he could've never imagined that Player Yuan would show up here for Meixiu.

"Our relationship doesn't concern you, nor should you stick your nose into our business. The only thing you need to know is that if you dare to bother Meixiu again, I will bring the Cultivator's Association to the ground."

"I—"

Before Chairman Zhao could even respond, Yuan suddenly moved his arm and grabbed Chairman Zhao's neck, lifting him into the air.

"C-Chairman!"

The guards there subconsciously reacted, but they were stopped by the old people that were following Chairman Zhao.

"If you don't want the chairman to die, you should stay still," said an old man with long white hair tied into a ponytail.

Meanwhile, Yuan spoke in a low voice while staring at Chairman Zhao.

"I am not asking you— I am telling you to leave her alone. Do you understand me?"

"Y-Yes... I-I understand..." Chairman Zhao uttered with much effort.

"Hmph!"

Yuan tossed Chairman Zhao to the side like trash after hearing his response.

He then turned around and said to Meifeng, "Let's go."

However, before he could walk very far, one of the old people there called out to him in a respectful voice, "Please wait a moment, young man."

Yuan stopped and turned around to see an old man standing behind him with his hands clasped together.

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Chapter 511 - Chairman Zhaos Resignation

Chapter 511 - Chairman Zhao's Resignation

"What is it?" Yuan asked the old man.

"I am surnamed Wu, and I would like to confirm something... Are you really a Spirit Master?" The old man asked him.

"What do you think?"

The old man showed a slight smile on his face before releasing his cultivation base, and to Yuan's surprise, he was also a Spirit Master!

'There are already other Spirit Masters beside me in this world?' Yuan thought to himself.

"Although I cannot see your face, I can tell that you're surprised by my cultivation base. You must be wondering how this is possible. If you visit my family at Mount Wu, I will tell you everything."

And before Yuan could even respond, the old man continued, "Don't worry, I am not related to Chairman Zhao, so whatever happened between you and him has nothing to do with me or my family. I came here today to see if the Cultivators' Association was worth my family's backing, but from the looks of it, we will have to reconsider some things."

"Hey, Old Wu, let's not try to pull a fast one before everyone here, or have you forgotten about our presence?" Another old man suddenly stepped forward and bowed to Yuan with his hands clasped.

"My surname is Zhi, and I am also a Spirit Master." The old man surnamed Zhi then released his Spirit Master cultivation base, surprising Yuan even more.

"Forget about Mount Wu. Come to my Mount Zhi instead. You won't regret it."

Then another person stepped forward— an old woman.

"Instead of fighting amongst ourselves, why don't we all cooperate together?" The old woman suggested.

She approached Yuan and said, "Surnamed Wang from the Wang Family. If you want to know how we reached Spirit Master and more about cultivation in general, come to the Jaded Garden situated outside the Yang City. We'll be more than happy to befriend a young genius such as yourself. If you're worried about your identity being revealed, I will let you know that we're really good at keeping secrets."

The old woman then leaned over his shoulders and whispered in a low voice that could only be heard by Yuan, "After all, we have managed to keep cultivation a secret from the rest of the world for many centuries..."

Yuan's body trembled after hearing the old woman's words.

They kept cultivation a secret from the rest of the world for many centuries? Does this mean that they have known about cultivation even way before Cultivation Online existed? If so, that explains why they were Spirit Masters.

"See you there in a month..." The old woman said to him before turning around and walking back to Chairman Zhao.

"Chairman Zhao, you have a lot of explaining to do for us. And don't you even dare think about lying to us because we will investigate the truth ourselves afterward."

Chairman Zhao, who was supposed to be an almighty figure, nodded his head in a powerless manner before the old woman and the other elders that were clearly more influential than Chairman Zhao.

Yuan lingered in the place for a few more moments before finally leaving the Cultivator's Association with Meifeng.

Although the people there wanted to follow him, they didn't dare to do so and reluctantly stayed behind.

"Young Master... you nearly scared me to death just now! I'm shocked that we even got to leave that place in one piece!" Meifeng sighed sometime later.

"I'm sorry. I got a little angry and my body started moving on its own." Yuan said to her, his hands still trembling a little.

"Young Master... Are you really Player Yuan?" Meifeng suddenly asked him.

"I will tell you everything once we return home, okay?"

"Of course." Meifeng nodded.

Once Yuan and Meifeng left the scene, the elders pressed Chairman Zhao for answers before everyone in the Cultivators' Association.

"If you don't tell us what happened, we'll speak with the council and have them deal with you."

Chairman Zhao sighed out loud before telling them the truth in a regretful voice.

"Che! What a shameless old man!" Someone there said out loud after Chairman Zhao revealed everything.

"Chairman Zhao, I am greatly disappointed in you. My Wang Family no longer wishes to be affiliated with the Cultivators' Association. Excuse me."

The old woman turned around and left the scene, followed by a few youngsters that came to this place with her.

The other elders also told Chairman Zhao the same thing before leaving the place.

As for the other people in the Cultivators' Association, they immediately started spreading news of everything that transpired there today through their phones, which spread like wildfire, shocking the world.

"What? The real Player Yuan showed up at the Cultivators' Association to warn Chairman Zhao? What did Chairman Zhao do to offend Player Yuan?"

"Chairman Zhao tried to force a young lady into joining the Cultivators' Association? And this young lady turned out to have a relationship with Player Yuan? Talk about karma!"

"Hahaha! Serves that old pervert right! I can't believe it! This is Player Yuan's first real appearance outside of Cultivation Online!"

"Player Yuan is already a Spirit Master? Isn't he also a Spirit Master in Cultivation Online? Just who is Player Yuan?! How does he keep achieving these seemingly impossible achievements?!"

The world was greatly shocked by what had happened at the Cultivators' Association, but the people were more interested in Player Yuan than what Chairman Zhao had done.

As for the Yu Family, they had managed to dodge a bullet when Chairman Zhao revealed everything, as he wasn't aware that the Yu Family had hired mercenaries to kidnap Meixiu.

However, the Yu Family was also shocked speechless to know that Meixiu had a relationship with Player Yuan, someone they have been looking for themselves.

They wanted to approach Meixiu for more information, but they were afraid of Player Yuan knocking on their doors.

After all, if Player Yuan dared to threaten to destroy the Cultivators' Association before the Chairman of the Cultivators' Association at their

main headquarters, what would stop him from visiting the Yu Family?

The Yu Family then called Mister Johnson to cancel the pending job.

What happened at the Cultivators' Association would be a hot topic on the news and the internet for the rest of the week, and Chairman Zhao would resign his position as Chairman the following day, which didn't surprise anyone when they learned about it.

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Chapter 512 - Hidden Experts

"Senior Wang, was that masked person really a Spirit Master?" One of the youngsters with Senior Wang asked her as they made their way back home on a private plane.

"Yes, that person was, without a doubt, a Spirit Master—the same level as me and the other elders," she confirmed.

"That young man also sounded like he was around your age. I cannot imagine how terrifying his talents must be to reach Spirit Master at such a young age, and it would be even more terrifying if he only started cultivating after Cultivation Online became a thing."

"That can't be possible, right?" Someone else there asked.

"The question is no longer whether it's possible or not, but how he achieved it..." Senior Wang said in a low voice.

"And whether he started cultivating before or after Cultivation Online doesn't really matter, as it won't change the fact that he's a Spirit Master at such a young age."

"Anyways, although our visit to the Cultivators' Association turned out to be a huge waste of time, I am actually glad that we went there, as I got to learn the existence of such a cultivation monster. The others in the family will go crazy once they learn about this young man."

"As for the other families... We'll definitely be fighting for him."

"If he's that famous Player Yuan, there's a good chance that he won't join any families, right?" Someone there asked.

"Yes, but it won't hurt to try." Senior Wang nodded.

"Who's this Player Yuan? I have never heard of him before." Another person said.

"You don't know Player Yuan? Don't you play Cultivation Online?"

"Why would I play a game about cultivation when I am already doing it in real life?"

"No wonder why you don't know him... Well, let me tell you about Player Yuan and his achievements..."

And for the rest of their flight, the young cultivators shared information about Player Yuan and his achievements with those that didn't know of his fame.

Meanwhile, after returning home, Yuan removed his mask and sat in the living room in an exhausted manner with sweat dripping down his face.

"Are you okay?" Meixiu asked him as she gently wiped the sweat off his face with a dry towel.

"Yes... I am fine... But that was more exhausting than I'd expected..."

"Since the Young Master cannot talk right now, I will explain everything for him," Meifeng said, and he proceeded to recall everything that had happened at the Cultivators' Association.

Meixiu expressed disbelief after hearing the situation.

"Y-You went there as Player Yuan, even threatening the Chairman? Heavens... Are you sure everything will be fine?" Meixiu spoke in a worried voice.

"We can't really say for now. Give it a few days and we'll see if anything will happen. However, they don't know the Young Master's identity, so they won't be able to do anything to him now even if they want to."

"But Young Master, you really surprised me today, and I am not talking about your identity as Player Yuan. I didn't even know you can act so domineering. You felt like an entirely different person today! I still have chills just thinking about it!" Meifeng said to him in a somewhat admiring voice.

"Well... Most of that was just an act since if I didn't act like that, they wouldn't have taken me seriously." Yuan smiled.

'Was it really just an act? It felt too realistic...' Meifeng thought to herself.

"Can you tell me more about your identity as Player Yuan? The Yu Family have asked me to investigate, but I came up with nothing."

Yuan nodded and proceeded to tell her about his identity as Player Yuan and some of the stuff he's done in Cultivation Online.

"I see... That explains why you're so powerful even in the real world... Turns out that you have been cultivating with a Divine-grade cultivation technique this entire time."

"What are we going to do now?" Meixiu asked them a moment later.

"Who knows, but I intend on going to the Jaded Garden to speak with those seniors next month," Yuan said.

"Are you sure that's a good idea? What if it's a trap?" Meifeng said.

"I think it'll be fine. If they really wanted to harm me, they could've done so back then. All three of them— and probably the other elders there were all Spirit Masters. There was no way I could've defeated them by myself. Furthermore, they didn't appear to be bad people."

"Why do you want to speak with them, though?" Meixiu then asked.

"I want to know more about the cultivation world... in this world. Apparently, they have known about cultivation since many centuries again, hence why they have been able to reach Spirit Master." Yuan said.

"So they're basically hidden experts that have been secretly cultivating for many years... I am very impressed by how they have managed to keep cultivation hidden from the public for so long." Meifeng said.

"Yes, I am too. That's why I want to speak with them."

"I will come with you," Meixiu said.

"Of course. I was going to ask you if you wanted to come later." Yuan nodded.

"Anyways, I am going to take a shower. My body is all sweaty."

Yuan then entered the bathroom and went to clean himself.

"You know that he was Player Yuan this entire time?" Meifeng asked Meixiu after he left.

"Yes."

"Well, aren't you a lucky one?"

"..."

Sometime later, Yuan returned to the living room, where Meixiu and Meifeng were watching the news.

"Look, Young Master. They are already talking about the incident at the Cultivators' Association— about Player Yuan."

Meifeng said as she turned the volume up a little more.

"Breaking news! Player Yuan has finally made an appearance today at the Cultivators' Association! He even confronted Chairman Zhao, threatening to destroy the Cultivators' Association if they continued to mess with his woman!"

"Who is this Meixiu that Player Yuan treasures so deeply?! Could it be his girlfriend?! Fiancee!? Perhaps even his wife?!"

"H-His wife?" Meixiu was speechless after she listened to how the news spoke about their relationship, making it seem as though they were lovers.

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Chapter 513 - Why Do You Reject My Existence?

"Yuan... Isn't that you?" Meixiu pointed at the television that was currently playing a recording from the surveillance camera at the Cultivators' Association, allowing everyone to witness the drama for themselves.

They could see two figures entering the building and walking straight towards the front.

A few moments later, the figure wearing a black mask suddenly smashed the metal table into pieces, shocking everyone there.

Then the guards surrounded the masked individuals, but they didn't dare advance any further for some reason, almost like there was an invisible force that kept them from approaching the masked figure.

A few minutes later, Chairman Zhao and the elders could be seen approaching the masked figure.

It was at this moment the masked figure walked in front of the Chairman before lifting him into the air by the neck.

A few more moments later, the masked figure tossed the Chairman like a child getting bored of their toy and walking away.

However, the masked figure was stopped by the elders, and after some conversation, the masked figure disappeared from the Cultivators' Association.

Of course, all of this was played without any sound. But even without any sound, the spectators could see how domineering that masked figure was,

and they had no doubt that he had the capabilities to destroy the Cultivators' Association from his demeanor alone.

Seeing Player Yuan for the first time, many people were in awe of his display of dominance, and those that were already fans of Player Yuan became even more obsessed with him.

"How embarrassing..." Yuan said with a bashful smile on his face after seeing himself acting so out of character, almost like he was watching a play.

"If I didn't know you were going to do this beforehand, I would have never guessed that masked figure would be you..." Meixiu said in a dumbfounded voice.

"I was actually afraid that the Young Master might accidentally kill the Chairman when he grabbed the Chairman by his neck," Meifeng said.

"K-Kill? Why would I do something so extreme?" Yuan was surprised to hear this.

"People do extreme things when they're angry..." Meifeng said.

"Even if that's true, I wouldn't kill someone just because I am angry... At least I hope I won't..."

Suddenly, Meixiu's phone started ringing.

"It's Yu Rou," Meixiu said to them before answering the phone.

"Hello—"

"Meixiu?! Are you watching the news right now?! Did Yuan really visit the Cultivators' Association today?!" Yu Rou asked her in an excited voice.

"Yes... It's true..." Meixiu said.

"Unbelievable..." Yu Rou's dumbfounded voice resounded after a moment of silence.

To think her brother would be so daring to storm the Cultivators' Association shortly after his recovery. She can only imagine what he might do in the future.

"Is he okay?" Yu Rou then asked.

"Yes, everything is okay... for now."

"I think he should be fine as long as nobody knows his identity." Yu Rou said.

"And even if the Cultivators' Association learns of his identity, I don't think it should cause any worries since a lot of people admires Player Yuan. There will be plenty of people willing to help him if he gets into any trouble."

"Anyways, just stay put for the next few days and see what happens. Also, keep me updated!" Yu Rou said.

"Okay."

An hour later, Wang Xiuying also gave them a call to make sure they were okay.

After dinner, Meifeng said, "Young Master, I will have to go back to work tomorrow, so tonight is our last night together."

"I see... It was fun, Miss Meifeng. It reminds me of the day when you were still taking care of me." Yuan said to her.

"And I will continue to take care of you from the shadows— until I am no longer needed," Meifeng said with a smile on her face.

That night, Meifeng snuggled closer to Yuan than usual.

"Good night, Young Master."

"Good night."

Once he fell asleep, Yuan returned to the land of dreams.

"Looks like you had quite some fun today." The handsome man appeared before him, just like he'd expected.

"Remember, what you experienced today is what it feels like to be the strong. As long as you're powerful, nobody will dare to defy you— nobody will dare to hurt those close to you."

Yuan silently stared at the handsome man with a slight frown on his face.

"What is it?" The man asked him.

"The way I acted today... You're affecting me, aren't you?" Yuan said in a low voice.

"I have no idea what you're talking about." The handsome man shrugged.

"Don't lie to me! I nearly killed Chairman Zhao today! If I didn't snap out of my anger, I would've snapped his neck in half instead when I had it in my grasp! I had this nearly uncontrollable desire to do so!"

The handsome man chuckled and said, "So what? You're simply acting true to yourself. You're worried that if you didn't kill him, he would eventually return to bother you and your loved ones again, right? That's why you had an urge to kill that man."

"Don't blame me for your own desires. After all, I am you. If you blame me, you're simply blaming yourself."

"Why do you reject my existence? You know, the more you refuse to accept me, the more difficult it will be for you when you must accept me, and that time will eventually come."

"..."

Yuan remained silent.

"Whatever. You don't need to accept me now, but eventually..."

The handsome man turned around and began disappearing into the mist.

Once the man was gone, the scenery changed, and even more of the handsome man's past began revealing itself to Yuan.

Yuan wanted to close his eyes and ignore the dream, but alas, since he was in a dream, even if he closed his eyes, he would still be able to see the dream. Therefore, he was forced to watch everything until he woke up.

"Haaaa... Why is this happening to me?" Yuan mumbled in a low voice.

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Chapter 514 Do You Believe In Reincarnation?

"Good morning, Young Master." Meifeng greeted him when he walked out of his room.

"Miss Meifeng? You're cooking breakfast today?" Yuan said.

"That's right. Since I am no longer on vacation, and I will be leaving soon, I want to do something for you before I leave."

"You're also up earlier than usual today, Young Master."

"Yes, I had another bad dream..." He sighed.

"You know, nightmares usually happen because you're stressed or when you're thinking too much about a certain thing. If there's something on your mind, you should let it out. Although I won't be here, you still have Meixiu. I'm sure you can tell her about it." Meifeng said to him.

"I will keep that in mind." Yuan nodded.

A few minutes later, Meixiu woke up and came out of her room, but to her surprise, her mother had already prepared breakfast for them.

"I only made enough for you two since I won't have the time to sit down and eat," Meifeng said after placing the food on the table.

"Thank you, Miss Meifeng. I hope you take more breaks so we can spend more time together." Yuan said.

Meifeng chuckled and said, "Although I would like that as well, I don't want to disturb your love nest too much."

"L-Love nest?!" Meixiu nearly spat out the water in her mouth when she heard Meifeng's words.

"Anyways, I will see you later. Stay safe, Young Master. If you ever run into any troubles, give me a call."

Meifeng then left the place shortly after.

Meixiu turned on the television while they ate so it wouldn't feel as awkward.

"As many of us had anticipated, Chairman Zhao from the Cultivators' Association has handed in his resignation letter after yesterday's drama and will no longer be affiliated with the Cultivators' Association!"

"Eh? He resigned? Things turned out much better than I'd expected." Yuan said after chewing and swallowing the food in his mouth.

"Wow! This food is amazing!" He then realized how great the food tasted and praised it loudly.

"Of course, your food also tastes great, Meixiu, but there's something different about Miss Meifeng's cooking!" Yuan added since he didn't want to upset her.

"Don't worry, I am well aware that I am still nowhere near my mother's level," she said in a calm voice.

"I don't think you should compare yourself to Miss Meifeng. Not only are you less experienced, but you're also much younger than her. If anything, you should compare yourself to people around your age."

Meixiu nodded.

Sometime later, Meixiu asked, "What are you going to do today?"

"Well, it's been a while since we've last played Cultivation Online. I am thinking about playing today."

"Okay. You can go ahead and play with me. I want to make sure that everything is actually fine before I relax."

"I understand."

"What about Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi?"

"It might be a bit early, so give them a text first."

Meixiu then texted Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi to see if they wanted to play.

[Yu Rou: Sorry, but I won't be able to play for a while since I will be busy with a few things.]

[Xia Jingyi: I am really close to a breakthrough... I think... So I am going to focus on cultivation for now. Sorry.]

After breakfast, Yuan went into his room and laid on the bed. He then wore the console and went inside Cultivation Online without any help for the first time.

"Welcome back, Brother Yuan." Xiao Hua and Lan Yingying greeted him.

"Good morning, you two."

"Have you dealt with whatever was troubling you?" Xiao Hua asked him.

"Yes, I have... for now."

Yuan then looked around and asked, "Feng Feng still hasn't returned?"

Suddenly, Feng Yuxiang's voice resounded, "I have been back for a while now."

A beautiful woman suddenly approached them from behind.

"It's been a while, Feng Feng," Yuan said to her with a smile on his face.

"Yes..." Feng Yuxiang nodded, still having some trouble looking straight into his eyes.

"Where are the others?" Feng Yuxiang then asked.

"They are currently busy, so it's just me today."

"I see..."

"Well... What would you like to do today?" Feng Yuxiang then asked him.

"Let's go somewhere quieter. How about that pond where we studied our techniques?" Yuan suggested.

"Sure!"

They then made their way towards the silent pond.

Once they arrived, Yuan approached the water and silently stared at the water.

"Did something happen to the Young Master? He feels a little different than usual." Feng Yuxiang noticed this and asked the other two.

"No idea..." They shook their heads.

After standing there for a couple of minutes, Yuan turned around and asked the three ladies, "Do you guys believe in reincarnation?"

"Reincarnation?" They repeated.

"It's a common topic in the world of cultivation, right?"

"Well... Although reincarnation is definitely a very popular belief amongst many cultivators from the Lower Heavens to the Supreme Heaven, nobody has ever been able to prove that it exists." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Do you believe it exists?" Yuan then asked.

"Of course. In case you forgot, Young Master, I am a phoenix—I am the embodiment of rebirth. However, I have never experienced reincarnation, nor do I know anybody that has been reincarnated."

"With that being said, even if someone is reincarnated, I don't think they will retain the memories of their previous life, or it would've been proven to truly exist by now." Feng Yuxiang said.

"I see..."

"Why are you suddenly interested in reincarnation, Young Master?"

"Well, it's been on my mind ever since someone mentioned it to me, and I am sort of in this deep hole that I cannot get out because of it..." Yuan sighed.

"If you ask me, I don't think it really matters if reincarnation is real or not. What happened in one's past life has already ended when that person died. Even if they somehow recall the memories of their previous life, what can they do about it? It's not as if they could reclaim the name of their previous life and act like they never died."

"That makes sense..." Yuan nodded, agreeing with Feng Yuxiang's words.

Chapter 515 Relentless Dragon Overwhelms the Nine Heavens

After thinking about the words Feng Yuxiang spoke to him, Yuan took a seat beside the pond and retrieved the ancient-rank technique Relentless Dragon Overwhelms the Nine Heavens.

"I am going to spend the rest of the day trying to comprehend this technique since it felt like I was getting close to understanding it when I stopped previously. You guys can do whatever." Yuan said to them before focusing on the technique.

Feng Yuxiang exchanged looks with the other two.

"Is it just me or does the Young Master feel a little different today?" Feng Yuxiang asked them.

"Just a little." Xiao Hua agreed.

"The Lord feels... A little more mature... Or at least the aura around him." Lan Yingying said.

"Let's just hope it doesn't mean anything bad." Feng Yuxiang sighed.

A few hours later, Yuan stood up and took a deep breath.

He then positioned himself that made it seem like he was prepared to throw a fist.

Yuan closed his eyes, and after a moment of silence, he snapped them open and released his fist, sending a powerful wave of spiritual energy that was shaped like a dragon towards the pond.

BOOM!

The entire ground shook as the pond was immediately erased from existence—the water and all, leaving a huge crater behind.

Yuan was left speechless by the destructive nature of the technique that erased an entire pond.

Fortunately for them, there were no living creatures within the pond.

<You have learned Relentless Dragon Overwhelms the Nine Heavens>

"Heavens... Young Master, where did you learn such a powerful technique?" Feng Yuxiang asked him afterward.

"The Dragon Temple," he said.

"Such a powerful strength, it must be Divine-rank or above."

"Yes, it's an Ancient-rank technique."

Yuan looked at the sky that was getting dark and said, "I am going to leave now. It might be some time before I return since it'll be a little busy for me. Also, you don't have to wait for me. If you want to do something, just go ahead and do it without me."

"Yingying, you wanted to look around the Lower Heavens, right? You can have Feng Feng and Xiao Hua take you around."

"I want to explore it with you..." Lan Yingying said.

"It's okay, the Nine Heavens is a vast universe. We'll be able to explore it together plenty when I am able to play more."

"If it's your wish..." Lan Yingying nodded.

"Then with that settled, I will see you guys later."

"See you later, Young Master."

"Stay safe, Brother Yuan."

After saying their goodbyes, Yuan logged out of the game and returned to practicing his movement technique in the real world whilst his servants began exploring the Lower Heavens without him, though it was mostly for Lan Yingying.

As much as he wanted to play Cultivation Online, there were simply too many things for him to do in the real world.

Once things calm down, he will return and fully explores the Nine Heavens.

"Yuan, you know the entire world is looking for you right now, right?" Meixiu said to him during his break from practicing the movement technique.

"Unless I reveal myself, I don't think anybody will be able to find me."

"I guess, but there are also people looking for me since they think that by finding me, they'll find you, which is true."

"The only people who know of your identity and location are the Yu Family, Doctor Wang and Wang Xiuying, Xia Jingyi, and Chairman Zhao—And I guess the agency that was hired by the Yu Family," Yuan said.

"This might become a little troublesome, especially since there are some people who we definitely cannot trust to keep your identity hidden. What do you want to do, Meixiu? Do you want to move out? It'll become problematic when our doors get flooded with people asking about Player Yuan. We have the funds to do so as well."

Meixiu pondered for a moment before speaking, "Where can we go, though?"

"Furthermore, even if they find me, they won't know that you're Player Yuan, so I think it would be fine."

"I still think it would be better for us to move once we find a good place."

"Yes, I agree. But for now, let's just see how things play out."

"Okay."

With that decided, Yuan and Meixiu proceeded to spend the next few days just improving their cultivation base.

During these few days, the Cultivations' Association had appointed a new Chairman, who made a public apology regarding the actions of the previous Chairman.

One can imagine why the new Chairman felt the need to apologize, as he didn't want the mysterious Player Yuan to hold a grudge against the Cultivators' Association because of the last Chairman, which would be a big blow to them even though Player Yuan was only a single individual.

Although Player Yuan was only a single individual, his influence inside Cultivation Online was comparable to multiple large companies combined, and nobody knows the true extent of his powers.

One might argue that being influential inside a video game isn't that important, but when one considers how much Cultivation Online currently affects the world, one would understand why people value Player Yuan so much.

Ding!

Early in the morning, Meixiu received a message from Yu Rou that told her to make a call whenever she was available.

Meixiu then called Yu Rou the next moment since she was free.

"Did something happen?" Meixiu asked.

"Yes. I have decided to join a cultivation faction, so I will be leaving the Yu Family soon." Yu Rou said, dumbfounding Meixiu.

After all, she'd only told Yuan about her decision to leave the Yu Family during her visit.

"Y-You're leaving the Yu Family as well? Why?" Meixiu couldn't help but ask her.

"Well, for one, now that cultivation has become fully incorporated into our world, other talents won't be as valued. In fact, I haven't had to participate in any lessons for a long time now. This is probably my parents' way of telling me to give up on music and focus solely on cultivation."

"Furthermore, I don't think I can stop blaming myself for what happened to you and Brother Tian due to my affiliation with the Yu Family. Hopefully, leaving the Yu Family can relieve some of that guilt..." Yu Rou sighed.

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Chapter 516 Eternal Lotuses

"Are you still worried about that? Neither Yuan nor I blame you for what happened— not even in the slightest." Meixiu said to her.

"I know, but it's just a feeling that I cannot shake off. Of course, I have other reasons why I want to leave the Yu Family— such as wanting to be independent like you and Brother Tian. I don't want to rely on the Yu Family forever, and I feel that if I remain in the family for any longer, I will never be able to leave."

After a moment of silence, Meixiu said, "I understand. Let me transfer you to Yuan so you can speak with him."

Meixiu then knocked on Yuan's room and said, "It's Yu Rou."

Yuan opened the door while wearing only his pants, his body soaked in sweat from exercising.

"Here you go..." Meixiu handed him the phone with a slightly rosy face.

"Good morning, Yu Rou." Yuan placed the phone on speakers then on his bed before speaking with her while he continued to exercise.

"You're exercising already? Don't push yourself too hard." Yu Rou said to him, as she could hear him exercising.

"Don't worry, I know when to stop," Yuan said.

"Anyways, I am calling to let you know that I have decided on a cultivation faction. I will be joining them next week. They're also in another city, so I will be moving out soon."

"Eh? Already?" Yuan stopped moving and expressed his surprise.

"I didn't think you'd leave so soon, and going to another city? How far are you traveling? What about this cultivation faction? What's their name?" Yuan bombarded her with questions.

"About 8,000 miles away, so I will be traveling pretty far."

"Eight thousand miles?! That's around 16 hours with a plane! Why are you going that far? Why can't you just join a cultivation faction that's already in this city?"

After all, it would only be more difficult for them to visit each other the further away they are from each other.

"Well, this cultivation faction is a little special, and even if it's a little far, I think it's worth it." Yu Rou said.

After a moment of silence, Yuan asked, "What's this cultivation faction called?"

"They are called Eternal Lotuses— it's a female-only cultivation faction that's led by the one and only White Lotus, who is a top player in Cultivation Online. They already have over a thousand talented cultivators, and they are a powerful faction and also one of the fastest-growing factions in the world."

"White Lotus?" Yuan recalled hearing this name before.

"White Lotus is a well-known player from a top 10 Legacy family. She is also a trustworthy individual according to my sources. I think it'll be fine if I go there."

"Furthermore, I won't be going there alone. I spoke with Xia Jingyi yesterday, and she agreed to come with me."

Knowing that Yu Rou won't be traveling alone made Yuan feel more relieved, but he was still worried.

After all, Yu Rou was only 16 years old.

"Brother, I know what you are thinking. I may be young, but I can take care of myself."

"I know you can... After all, you took care of me for many years. However, it's a brother's duty to worry about his sister, right?" Yuan said with a gentle smile on his face.

"Anyways, have you spoken to your parents about this yet?" He then asked.

"No... I haven't, nor do I plan on telling them since they will definitely refuse to let me go," she responded calmly.

"How long do you plan on staying there? In the Eternal Lotuses?"

"I don't know... But it's going to be at least a couple of years."

"Give me the address so that we can visit you in the future when we have the time."

"Of course, but I don't think they allow male visitors inside their place, so I will have to meet you somewhere else."

"That's fine."

Yuan and Yu Rou spoke to each other for many minutes until Yu Rou had to go.

"I will call you later, Brother."

"Okay."

After hanging up, Yuan asked Meixiu, "Do you think we can do a performance before Yu Rou leaves in a week? I don't care what kind of performance. Even a contest is okay as long as I get to play an instrument."

"You want to perform in public right now? That's a little risky, no?"

"I think it should be fine. I want to fulfill Yu Rou's dream a little before she leaves."

"Alright... I will try to do something about it."

"Thank you, Meixiu."

Yuan returned to his training shortly after, and Meixiu began looking for a place where he could perform.

Two days later, Meixiu found a place and said, "There's going to be a small piano contest in five days, and it's the earliest one I can find."

"Five days... Right when Yu Rou leaves, huh? Let's do it."

"I have already signed us up for it. It'll start at 8 AM in the morning, but we won't be on stage until 10 AM."

"Great. Now we just need to let Yu Rou know."

Meixiu then called Yu Rou.

"Yu Rou, I have a surprise for you. Can you come to this location before 10 AM in the morning?"

"10 AM? Why? What's going to happen in this place? Our flight is at 1 PM." Yu Rou asked.

"It's okay, you can go to the airport from that place. As for why... It's a surprise. Don't worry, it won't last long at all— a few minutes at most."

"Okay... I will be there." Yu Rou agreed.

"You won't regret it! I promise!"

After hanging up, Yuan and Meixiu began preparing for the small contest.

Meanwhile, Yu Rou called Xia Jingyi to let her know that they'll be leaving a little earlier than planned to make a pitstop before their flight.

And in the blink of an eye, five days passed.

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Chapter 517 Approaching the Stage

Early in the morning, Yu Rou opened the drawers to her desk and retrieved two items— a yellow envelope and a white letter that she had just written last night.

Yu Rou placed the yellow envelope inside her large suitcase and the white letter on her desk.

After making sure that she had everything, she left the building and took a taxi to Xia Jingyi's living quarters, not even bothering to use her family limousine.

"Good morning, Yu Rou." Xia Jingyi greeted her at the door.

"Morning, Jingyi. Are you ready?"

"Yes, I am."

Yu Rou looked at her watch; it was 9 AM.

"We should arrive at the location my brother provided in 30 minutes. I wonder what he had planned for us."

"If you're really curious, you can look that place up and see if there are any events." Xia Jingyi suggested.

However, Yu Rou shook her head and said, "That's no good. My brother wanted to surprise me, so I will let him surprise me. It would no longer be a surprise if I know what to expect."

Xia Jingyi nodded, and after saying her goodbyes to her parents, she entered her family's limousine with Yu Rou.

"Please take care of our daughter, Yu Rou." Xia Jingyi's parents said to Yu Rou.

"Of course. I will make sure nothing happens to her! I should also take this chance to thank you for letting my brother stay in your apartments." Yu Rou patted her chest with a confident smile.

"You don't have to thank us. If anything, we should be the ones apologizing for allowing that incident to occur. We'll make sure to increase security in that apartment."

Yu Rou nodded, and she entered the car with Xia Jingyi while the driver packed their suitcases inside the car trunk.

Once they were prepared, the limousine began driving towards the location given by Yuan.

Meanwhile, Yuan and Meixiu approached the reception inside a large building.

"Hello, we're here to participate in the contest," Meixiu said to the receptionist, who was a little startled when she saw their appearance, as both of them were wearing masks.

"W-What is the name of the participant?" The receptionist then asked.

"Tian Yang of Divine Melody," she said.

"Please give me a moment to look through the system."

"I have confirmed your registration. I will check you in now. You will be called onto the stage at 10 AM. Here's your identification card. You can wait in the spectator area or wait in the back room."

After accepting his identification card, Yuan and Meixiu proceeded to the spectators' area, where hundreds of spectators were watching the current

contestant playing the piano.

"It's been too long... I am starting to feel a little nervous..." Yuan said with a smile behind his mask.

"You'll be fine," Meixiu said.

The two of them proceeded to watch contestants take their turns at the piano, and because of their masks, they attracted quite the attention from the people around them.

Though, since masks weren't prohibited, nobody really approached them.

Around 9:40 AM, Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi pulled up at the location and left the car.

"This is..." Yu Rou looked at the large banner hanging above the building and immediately knew what was going on.

"It's a music contest... Why did your brother tell us to come here?" Xia Jingyi asked, as she wasn't aware of his recovery.

Yu Rou merely showed a gentle smile on her face, and she said, "Who knows. Let's go inside."

Upon reaching the receptionist, before they could even speak, the receptionist behind the desk recognized Yu Rou's face and spoke in an excited voice, "Aren't you Lady Yu Rou?! What are you doing here?!"

The people around them heard the name 'Yu Rou' and turned to look in their direction with interest.

"Yu Rou?! That music genius who won many international competitions?!"

"Hello, I am here to spectate the contest." Yu Rou said with a friendly smile on her face.

Because of her background, she was very famous within the music industry, hence why the receptionist immediately recognized her.

"S-Spectate the contest?" The receptionist was taken by surprise by her words.

Why would someone famous like Yu Rou come to witness some small music competition? It didn't make sense. After all, there was nobody famous playing today.

However, the receptionist didn't question her and quickly said, "Of course! Please follow me to the VIP seats."

The receptionist then led Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi to the VIP seats that were in front of the stage.

Their presence quickly attracted the spectators there, and even the contestant was affected by their presence.

"Isn't that Yu Rou from the Yu Family? What's a bigshot like her doing here?"

"Who knows... Maybe she's bored?"

"Speaking of Yu Rou, I was there to witness her last performance, and it was beyond amazing. I wonder when she'll do another performance. It's been a while since she performed, too."

The quiet spectators' area turned a little noisy with Yu Rou's appearance, and although Xia Jingyi wasn't as famous as Yu Rou, there were some people who recognized her there.

Time passed quickly.

The time was 10:05 AM.

"Our next contestant will be from the Divine Melody. Please welcome Tian Yang." The speakers announced after the last contestant got off the stage.

"Divine Melody? What company is that? I have never heard of them."

"Me neither. I also don't know of any Tian Yang. Perhaps it's a new company."

"Haha... Who would create a new music company at this time? They should've started a cultivation faction instead!"

Although it seemed like there was nobody interested in this unknown contestant, if one looked at Yu Rou's face right now, they would see pure excitement and anticipation.

A few moments later, the spectators there could see a figure wearing a black mask slowly approaching the stage from the spectators' area, and there was this unfathomable aura him that made the people there stop talking to focus on him.

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Chapter 518 Tian Yang

Although nobody there besides Meixiu and Yu Rou knew the identity of the masked contestant, they could somehow tell that he was a professional just by the manner he walked onto the stage and how he sat behind the piano.

"Yu Rou, this person... He's very skilled." Xia Jingyi said with a serious expression on her face.

"I think so too." Yu Rou nodded, still pretending to be ignorant.

Once the atmosphere was completely silent, Yuan placed his hands on the piano keyboard and started playing the piano.

The audience felt chills going down their spine when they heard the first 10 notes being played, and their ears vibrated with bliss.

They have never heard or seen such a flawless performance before, nor did they expect to witness something this profound in such a small competition.

Yuan's performance continued to be played flawlessly for the next four minutes, playing the whole song without making a single mistake.

Every movement he made seemed to be made with elegance and grace, looking like he was dancing while playing the instrument.

The spectators quickly began speculating that Yuan was a professional disguised as a beginner to surprise them, but they were unable to guess his identity.

"Heavens... Who is this person?"

The judges there were left speechless by Yuan's performance. In fact, they only needed to listen to his performance for half a minute to be convinced that he was going to win this competition without anyone getting close.

The whole performance only lasted 4 minutes, but it felt like only a few seconds had passed for the spectators, as they were fully absorbed in his performance, feeling like they were in a dream-like state throughout the whole performance.

After playing his last note, Yuan stood up and turned to face the dazed audience before giving them a bow.

The audience remained silent for another moment before they exploded with cheering and admiration.

"That was amazing!"

"Play another song!"

"Encore!"

The judges agreed with the audience, and one of them said, "Contestant Tian Yang, can you do us a favor and play another song? You can pick the song. And don't worry, it won't affect your scores regardless of your performance."

Yuan pondered for a moment before nodding his head and returning to his seat behind the piano.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan began playing another song.

However, nobody in the audience recognized this song— nobody but Yu Rou.

Yu Rou's eyes widened with shock when she heard this song.

"Brother..." she muttered in a low voice, trying her best to not shed any tears in public.

The song being played by Yuan was a song he'd created for her when he was still actively playing for the Yu Family.

However, there weren't any good memories behind this song, as the day after he created this song, Yuan's body started to break.

This song didn't last long and only lasted half as long as the previous song, but it was so intensive and fast-paced that it sounded longer than the previous song, and there were more than twice as many notes in this song.

After finishing his second song, Yuan didn't stand up and waited for ten seconds before starting his third song.

Despite this, none of the judges or spectators complained. In fact, even the contestants there remained silent, as they knew that if they played after his performance, it would only make themselves look bad.

When she heard the third song, Meixiu could feel her heart throbbing faster and faster, as this was her favorite song, and memories began flowing inside her head.

Whenever she was sad and brought to tears by her training, Yuan would play this song for her before comforting her with a hug, and it would work every single time, allowing her to endure another day of training.

About three minutes later, Yuan stopped playing and stood up.

He then bowed to the audience for a second time.

The audience immediately erupted into a frenzy this time, and it was much louder than the previous cheering.

Yuan started leaving the stage a moment later, and when the judges saw this, they stopped him.

"W-Wait a minute, contestant Tian Yang!"

"What's the matter?" Yuan turned to look at them.

"Can you tell us a little more about yourself? Who taught you how to play the piano? How long have you been playing?" The judges asked him, as they wanted to obtain some information from him so that they could use that information to guess his identity.

Yuan then said, "I have been playing since I was young. As for my teachers... I had many teachers throughout my career— too much to name."

"You can tell us a few names if it's too many."

"I'm sorry, but I'd rather not." Yuan politely refused.

"Then can you tell us how old are you currently?" Another judge asked him.

"I am currently 18 years old, approaching 19," he said.

"Y-You're only 18 years old?!"

The judges were shocked to learn this information.

If this information was true, then one can only imagine how far he'll go when he's already this talented at his young age.

However, this raised more questions than answered.

Although there were many talented individuals at his age playing professionally in the music industry, the judges didn't know of any professional at Yuan's age with his level of talents— and this was true even for the older professionals, so does this mean he's actually a new pianist who's just stepping into the professional scene?

Where has he been this entire time? How can someone this talented remain as a nobody?

The judges proceeded to ask Yuan a few more questions, hoping to learn more about him, but Yuan skillfully answered their questions without giving them any information that would give away his identity.

The judges eventually gave up and allowed him to leave the stage.

Of course, the moment he left the stage, the spectators surrounded him for autographs even though this was his first appearance, as they were certain that he will become famous in the industry with his talents.

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Chapter 519 Tian Yang 2

The situation got so bad that guards had to intervene.

After many minutes of struggling to get the spectators back into their seats, Yuan approached Yu Rou and said, "You must be Yu Rou from the Yu Family. I have heard a lot about you from my teachers. Do you have some time right now? I'd like to speak with you."

Yu Rou nodded with a calm expression on her face, "I do."

"Jingyi, you can come too." Yu Rou said to her.

"A-Are you sure?" Xia Jingyi asked.

"Yes, it's fine," Yuan confirmed.

Xia Jingyi nodded and followed them outside while feeling like she'd met with Tian Yang before.

Once Yuan left the place, the contestants were finally able to breathe properly, but none of them wanted to go on the stage anymore.

The judges understood their feelings and eventually decided to end the contest earlier than anticipated since nobody wanted to play the piano after Yuan's godlike performance.

And even if they were to play the piano, the results were obvious.

Once they were outside and in a secluded area, Yuan said, "What did you think of my performance? Was it like how you remembered?"

Yu Rou didn't say anything and immediately went for the hug, taking Xia Jingyi by surprise.

"Y-Yu Rou?" Xia Jingyi truly didn't expect Yu Rou to suddenly hug a stranger.

Or maybe she knew Tian Yang and had been acting like she didn't.

"Do you not recognize my voice?" Yuan turned to look at Xia Jingyi as he embraced Yu Rou.

Xia Jingyi's eyes widened with shock upon her realization.

"H-H-How?!"

One couldn't blame Xia Jingyi for not recognizing Yuan until now, as nobody would imagine that a cripple who couldn't move for many years would suddenly be able to move, much less play the piano flawlessly.

However, this explained everything. If it was Yuan, who was recognized as a once-in-a-lifetime genius, the flawless performance made perfect sense.

"It just happened, I guess."

"A-Are you really Yu Rou's brother...?" Xia Jingyi still held some doubt, as it was too hard to believe.

"Jingyi, do you think I would touch another man that's not my brother, much less hug him?" Yu Rou said to her as her arms wrapped around Yuan's body intimately.

"N-No..." Xia Jingyi shook her head.

"Then there's your answer. I know it's hard to believe, but it's true."

"..."

Xia Jingyi then watched in silence as Yu Rou and Yuan hug each other for a few more moments.

"I want us to stay like this forever, but unfortunately, we don't have much time here." Yu Rou said as she released him from her embrace.

"Since it's your decision, I won't try to convince you to stay. After all, you were the one who decided to take this path." Yuan said to her.

"Thank you for understanding, brother. I promise you that I will become a strong cultivator during our next visit."

Yuan smiled underneath his mask and said, "I look forward to when that day comes."

Yu Rou nodded and then turned to look at the masked figure standing behind Yuan.

"I already told you this before you left the Yu Family, but let me say this again. Please take care of my brother, Meixiu."

"I will," she responded in a calm voice.

Yuan then said, "And please take care of my sister, Jingyi."

"I'm afraid that I will be the one being taken care of..." Xia Jingyi said with a bashful smile.

Yuan shook his head and said, "It's because I know that you'll be with Yu Rou that I am not as worried about her. If she was going alone, I would probably be trying to convince her to stay now."

"You really have no trust in me, huh." Yu Rou sighed.

"You know that's not true." Yuan chuckled.

He then asked her, "Will you be playing Cultivation Online over there?"

Yu Rou nodded and said, "We'll be cultivating in Cultivation Online and the real world as a group. However, I won't be able to play with you as often since I have to be with the others."

"That's fine. As long as we can still meet each other in Cultivation Online." Yuan said, and he continued, "When you arrive at that place, try to log inside Cultivation Online. I have one last surprise for you."

"Alright. I will let you know when I will be available." Yu Rou nodded.

After talking to each other for some more, Yu Rou gave Yuan one more tight embrace before returning to the car with Xia Jingyi and heading to the airport.

"Goodbye, Meixiu, Brother Tian."

"Until next time, Yu Rou."

Once Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi left the scene, Yuan said to Meixiu, "Let's go home too."

"What about the contest results?" Meixiu asked.

"I don't really care about the results since I didn't come here for the reward," Yuan said.

"Okay, then let's go home."

They also returned home shortly after.

Meanwhile, Yuan's performance at the small contest was uploaded to the internet by one of the judges when they got their hands on the replay.

The video quickly acquired traction, especially within the musician circles.

[Who is this Tian Yang?! I have never heard of him before!]

[Does anyone have information on this genius?!]

[18 years old?! I don't believe it! How can someone so young play so flawlessly?!]

There were only two things that came to one's mind when one watched the video of Yuan's piano performance.

Awe and doubt.

They were in awe of Yuan's godlike talents and performance, but they also doubted his identity as an 18-year-old. After all, even the old experts who have decades of experience could not do so with such perfection.

Shortly after the video went public, countless families across the world began investigating Tian Yang, and they started with his company Divine Melody that was only recently created.

However, the owner of the company and its employers were all private information that cannot be found through normal means, so those with influence began making phone calls to people with authority and influence in hopes of finding more information about the Divine Melody and Tian Yang.

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Chapter 520 White Envelope

"Dear! Look at this!"

Tang Lee stormed inside Yu Yong's room as he worked on the company.

"What happened?" Yu Yong looked at her with his eyebrows raised. It has been a very long time since he has last seen his wife act so excited.

Tang Lee placed her laptop in front of him and played the video of Yuan's performance as Tian Yang.

"T-This is—!" Yu Yong stood up from shock after watching the performance for merely a couple of seconds.

"This is a genius! A true genius! Who is this masked man?!" Yu Yong quickly asked, but his eyes were still captivated by Yuan's flawless performance.

"His name is Tian Yang, and he's currently with a new company named Divine Melody. However, nobody knows much if anything about this individual or the company itself since they both showed up out of the blue." Tang Lee explained to him.

"Nobody? How is that possible? Who's the owner of the company?"

"There are already plenty of people asking around, but nobody seems to have any idea."

"Nobody? I don't believe it!"

Yu Yong immediately retrieved his cell phone and started making calls to many prominent people within the industry.

"Mister Nick, have you heard about a company called Divine Melody?" Yu Yong asked.

"Haha... Mister Yu... Trust me, I have heard this name so much today that I am starting to go crazy. You're calling me to ask about Tian Yang, right? Unfortunately, I have no information on him."

"I see..."

Yu Yong quickly hung up and proceeded to call another person.

"Mister Yu, if you're calling me about the Divine Melody or Tian Yang, I have no clue." The person who picked up the phone gave it to him straight.

"Not even you know about them?"

"Unfortunately, whoever made the company knew very well what they were doing and kept everything tightly sealed. Unless we find out who helped created this company, we may never know more about them."

"Have you tried hacking the system?" Yu Yong then asked.

"Trust me, you're not the first person to ask me that, and if it was successful, I wouldn't be so empty-handed right now."

"I understand. Keep me updated if you find anything." Yu Yong said before hanging up.

Yu Yong proceeded to call many more people, but after an hour of effort, he still knew nothing about the company Divine Melody or Tian Yang.

After pondering, Yu Yong decided to call Mister Johnson, who was highly reputable when it comes to intelligence and this kind of subject.

"Master Yu, let me guess... This is about the Divine Melody."

Yu Yong could already guess the results after hearing Mister Johnson's opening sentence.

"What do you know?" Yu Yong still asked.

"Nothing... as for right now. We have already received a dozen requests to find information on the company and Tian Yang, but we have nothing as of this moment."

"Is there no way to contact this company?" Yu Yong asked.

"There is a way— one way. The company Divine Melody has one contact info— an email address. This is our only lead, and we have already tried to contact them, so we're just waiting for a response right now."

"What's the email address? I will try to reach out to them myself, and I swear to god if you ask me to pay for—"

"Don't worry, I won't ask for anything. Here's the email address..."

After receiving the email address from Mister Johnson, Yu Yong hung up and opened his laptop.

"No luck?" Tang Lee returned to his room sometime later and asked him.

"Nope. Whoever created the company seems to have expected this situation and has extensive knowledge regarding how things work so we cannot dig out any information about them. However, not all is lost, since we have an email address to contact the company."

"What if that doesn't work?" Tang Lee asked.

"Then we can only wait until they reveal themselves or make a mistake." Yu Yong said.

Meanwhile, back inside their apartment, Meixiu stared at her laptop with her eyebrows raised.

After participating in the contest, their Divine Melody company email suddenly received over a thousand emails, and they only kept on coming.

"Did something happen?" Yuan noticed her expression during his training and decided to ask her.

She nodded and explained it to him.

"Ah, that's normal. They're most likely trying to recruit me into their company." Yuan said, as he has plenty of experience with this even though he was already working for the Yu Family.

"Yuan, look at this email." Meixiu pointed to a certain email on the laptop screen.

Yuan looked at it with his divine sense and laughed, "The Yu Family, too? Well, I am not surprised at all. That's how they found me in the first place — because of a video that had gone viral."

"Are you going to answer to any of them?" Yuan then asked her.

"No... I think it would be better if we ignore them for now."

"I think so too." Yuan nodded, agreeing with her.

That afternoon, in Yu Rou's living quarters, one of the servants knocked on her door, completely unaware that she'd left the family.

"Young Lady, you have been summoned by the Masters." The servant said, patiently waiting outside her door.

When nobody responded a minute later, the servant knocked on her doors again and repeated.

"Young Lady, you have been summoned by the Masters."

After knocking a couple more times, the servant eventually decided to enter the room in case Yu Rou was playing Cultivation Online.

"Excuse me, Young Lady."

The servant opened the door, but to her surprise, the room was completely empty.

"Eh? Where's the Young Lady?"

The servants are usually aware of her schedule, and Yu Rou would always let someone know if she'd gone somewhere outside. However, there was no news from her today, and even her limousine was parked outside, so where did she go?

After entering the room, the servant noticed the white envelope on the desk.

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Chapter 521 Bring Her Back!

"Master! Master! We have an emergency!"

A servant working in the Yu Family's headquarters urgently knocked on Yu Yong's doors.

"Enter!" Yu Yong shouted from inside the room with a bad feeling in his guts.

Once the servant entered the room, he asked her, "What happened?"

"I-It's about the Young Lady! She has left the family!" The servant exclaimed.

"What?"

It took a minute for Yu Yong to process those words.

Once he eventually digested the situation, he immediately frowned and said, "What the heck are you talking about? Why would Yu Rou suddenly leave the family?"

"T-This letter was left inside the Young Lady's room when someone went to notify her of your summoning!" The servant quickly placed the white envelope that had been opened on Yu Yong's desk before taking a few steps back.

Yu Yong stared at the white envelope that emitted an ominous aura for a few moments before picking it up and reading the contents inside.

[Dear father and mother, I have decided to leave the Yu Family to join the cultivation faction Eternal Lotuses. You may be wondering why I made this

decision. It's simple. I disapprove of how you all treated Brother Tian and Meixiu, and I cannot get rid of this guilt as the daughter of the Yu Family that mistreated them. Therefore, I have decided to leave.]

[Don't even bother trying to convince me to return, because I won't return even if it's the last thing I do. If you're thinking about forcing me back like how you tried to force Meixiu back into the family just to sell her to Chairman Zhao, don't bother— unless you want to offend the entire Eternal Lotuses that's the number one power within their city.]

[However, as much as I despise the family, I must thank you for giving me life and allowing me to meet with Brother Tian.]

Yu Yong read the letter while his entire body trembled from anger.

"What an ungrateful child!" Yu Yong slammed the desk before him, creating a crack on the surface and knocking down the stacked documents to the floor.

"Call my wife here!" Yu Yong turned to look at the servant and spoke in a commanding voice.

"Right away, Master!"

The servant immediately rushed outside and went to notify Tang Lee of the situation.

Tang Lee arrived before Yu Yong a few minutes later with a deep frown on her face.

"Is it true— that Yu Rou left the family to join some cultivation faction?" Tang Lee asked Yu Yong who reluctantly nodded his head.

"Then why are you still sitting there?! Hurry up and bring her back!" Tang Lee shouted.

Unlike Yuan who was adopted into the family, Yu Rou was a true descendant of the Yu Family, meaning that she was worth much more to the Yu Family despite being much less talented than Yuan.

Furthermore, Yu Rou was their only child, meaning that if she leaves, they will have nobody to continue the Yu Family unless they give birth to another child.

Even if she was less talented than Yuan, she could at least fulfill her duties as a child of the Yu Family and continue their legacy.

However, that was much easier said than done, especially since Tang Lee was already past that age.

While she could still give birth, it would come with huge risks to her and the unborn baby's health, so unless absolutely have to, it wasn't an option.

"You have no idea. This situation isn't as easy as you think!" Yu Yong shouted back at her.

"Yu Rou went to join the Eternal Lotuses! Although they're not as powerful as the Cultivators' Association, their influence is on par with them! We cannot simply force her to return like Meixiu!"

"Eternal Lotuses? I have never heard of them." Tang Lee said.

"Look them up. They're a female-only cultivation faction led by White Lotus, a famous Cultivation Online player who belongs to a Legacy Family in the top 10. There are also many descendants from the Legacy Family within their ranks. We cannot afford to offend them."

"Then what are we supposed to do?"

"There is nothing we can do right now except give Yu Rou some time to calm her head. Once she's calm, we will try to convince her to return. Otherwise, we'll have to give up on her and make another child." Yu Yong said.

"That's easy for you to say since you don't have to carry a baby around for 9 months, nor do you have to do any of the hard labor! What about my feelings?! I am no longer at the age where it's safe to conceive!" Tang Lee shouted.

"Calm down. This is only the worst-case scenario. There are definitely other methods, but for now, let's just wait and see what happens." Yu Yong said.

"Hmph!" Tang Lee didn't say anything and stormed outside the room in angry steps.

Time passed quickly, and the following day, Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi arrived at their destination after their plane landed.

Once they left the airport, Yu Rou looked around until she found an old woman holding a sign with their names, and she approached this woman.

"Hello, I am Yu Rou, and this is Xia Jingyi."

"It's nice to finally meet you, Lady Yu Rou and Lady Xia Jingyi. You can call me Grandma Yin. I am in charge of bringing the newcomers to the Eternal Lotuses' headquarters and a few other things."

Grandma Yin then showed them to the car that was a white limousine.

Once they were prepared to leave, Grandma Yin sat in the back with Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi while the driver, who was also a female, drove to the Eternal Lotuses' headquarters.

"Allow me to give you a brief introduction to the Eternal Lotuses even though I am sure that you are already aware of such information. It's mostly for formalities."

Yu Rou nodded, and Grandma Yin proceeded to explain to them about the Eternal Lotuses.

Chapter 522 White Lotus

"As you should know by now, the Eternal Lotuses is a female-only cultivation faction created by White Lotus, who belongs to a Legacy Family ranked in the top 10. She is also a top player inside Cultivation Online who has recently managed to reach peak Spirit Warrior. As for her real-life cultivation, she has achieved 1st level Spirit Warrior just three days ago."

"Wow! 1st level Spirit Warrior!" Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi expressed awe upon hearing White Lotus' impressive cultivation speed.

Compared to her, they were still in the mid-levels as a Spirit Apprentice, and they were considered geniuses by many people.

Of course, compared to Yuan, she was still lacking a little, but if Yu Rou compared everyone with Yuan, the world would look a lot less interesting and a lot more lackluster.

"Although the Eternal Lotuses has only recently been made public, it was actually created shortly after Cultivation Online became a thing."

"Oooh, I didn't know that." Yu Rou said.

"Me neither." Xia Jingyi said afterward.

"Now let me tell you about what will happen once we arrive at the headquarters. Although we have already accepted both of you into Eternal Lotuses, you're actually still required to partake in a simple test. If you've gone to the Cultivators' Association to receive your cultivation card, then you should already know what to expect. It's mostly to gauge your talents and to see how we should train you." Grandma Yin said.

And she continued, "There are a few physical tests, but those are mostly just to see your strength and test your limits."

"Ummm... Can we fail these tests? What happens if we do?" Xia Jingyi suddenly asked.

"It's fine if you fail these tests. It just means that we will need to train you more than others so you can catch up." Grandma Yin responded with a calm smile on her face.

"Once you're officially accepted into the Eternal Lotuses, you will live within the headquarters and be assigned a leader that is usually in charge of about a hundred people. If you wish to leave the headquarters to go outside for whatever reasons, you must speak to an elder or your leader."

"This is mostly for your safety, as our headquarters are situated a little far from society."

"What about visitors? Can we have visitors? I have a brother, and he told me that he'd visit me from time to time." Yu Rou asked.

"Visitors are only allowed inside the headquarters if they're female, but they must be screened. If they're a man, like your brother, or they failed the screening, you can only meet them outside the headquarters."

"I thought so..." Yu Rou sighed.

"There will also be rules that must be followed as a fellow member of the faction, but we'll get into more of that once we actually arrive."

About three hours later, the limousine stopped right outside an unknown wilderness.

"We're here."

Grandma Yin said to them.

Once they got out of the car and retrieved their luggage, Grandma Yin led the two girls inside the wilderness, where they continued to walk for

another half an hour before they arrive before a large gate that was guarded by a group of female guards.

"Welcome back, Elder Yin." The guards greeted Grandma Yin with respect.

"I have returned with the newcomers," she said to them.

"Elder Yin... You know the leader doesn't like it when you go outside for these minor tasks that could be done by the others..." One of the guards said to her.

Grandma Yin laughed and said, "I was bored."

"Anyways, let's take our newcomers to the welcoming area."

Once the gates were opened, Grandma Yin led Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi inside the place and then to a spacious area that had around 40 other people gathered, all of them newcomers just like them.

After waiting for another hour for a couple more people to show up, a beautiful young woman with white hair appeared before the newcomers.

When the newcomers saw this beautiful young woman, they all greeted her with respect.

"Good morning, Senior White Lotus."

'That's White Lotus?' Xia Jingyi looked at her unique white hair with interest, as this was her first time seeing her in person.

It was the same for Yu Rou, but she knew how White Lotus looked beforehand due to the internet.

"My name is Bai Lianhua or White Lotus. I'd prefer it if you addressed me with the former while we're in the real world and the latter whenever we're inside Cultivation Online." Bai Lianhua said to them in a gentle voice that didn't fit her seemingly cold expression.

"I will speak with you all again later, but for now, let's get your living quarters situated. And since many of you have just experienced a long journey, we will be starting the examinations tomorrow. With that being said, you're not allowed to wander the place without supervision since you're still not part of the Eternal Lotuses. If you're caught sneaking around, we'll immediately send you home."

After saying a couple of sentences, Bai Lianhua turned around and disappeared.

"Senior Bai is really cool..."

"Right? I think I am in love..."

The newcomers were definitely in awe of Bai Lianhua's overwhelming presence.

Sometime later, the ladies that came from all over the world were led to the living quarters and were assigned their room.

Everybody had to share a room with another individual, and since Yu Rou came with Xia Jingyi, they were automatically assigned to be in the same room, which was exactly what they wanted.

"We will call you tomorrow when it's time to do the examinations. Until then, you're free to do whatever you want with the exception of roaming. If you wish to go somewhere, you can speak with a member wearing this white uniform, and there will always be someone guarding outside."

The members instructed the newcomers.

Once that was done, the newcomers retired inside the room for the rest of the day.

Chapter 523 Gif

"Wow, this place is bigger than I'd expected." Xia Jingyi said as she looked around the room that had two bedrooms, a living room, a bathroom, a kitchen, and even a small backyard.

"It feels like we're studying aboard as exchange students." Yu Rou smiled.

"Right? I was thinking the same thing!"

"What should we do now?" Xia Jingyi asked.

Yu Rou pondered for a moment before speaking, "Since we have the whole day to ourselves, I will use this time to meet with Brother Tian in Cultivation Online just like I'd promised him."

Yu Rou then unpacked her luggage, retrieving the console.

"Can I join you?" Xia Jingyi asked.

"Of course. I don't see why you can't." Yu Rou nodded.

Once everything was set up, Yu Rou called Meixiu to tell them that they'd arrived safely and will be entering Cultivation Online shortly.

"Although it's morning here, it should be nighttime where you are right now, right?"

"Yes. We were just getting ready to sleep, but I will let Yuan know."

Meixiu then knocked on Yuan's door and told him about Yu Rou.

"Hello? Yu Rou? Are you going to enter Cultivation Online in a bit? I will meet you there." Yuan said to her.

"Sorry for the inconvenience. I know it's late over there." Yu Rou said.

"Don't worry, this isn't my first time staying up late." Yuan chuckled.

"Then I will see you in a bit alongside Jingyi."

"Alright."

After hanging up the phone, Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi logged into Cultivation Online and waited for Yuan and Meixiu to appear.

Meixiu appeared a few minutes later, but Yuan was nowhere to be seen.

"Where's my brother?" Yu Rou asked Meixiu.

"He's coming here. He left the city for a moment recently to do something." Meixiu explained to her.

"Okay."

Sometime later, Yuan returned to the city and met up with the others.

"Where's Feng Feng and the others?" Yu Rou asked him.

"Oh, I told them to explore the Lower Heavens without me since I won't be active for god-knows-how-long," he said.

"I see... Then let's go somewhere more private so we can talk." Yu Rou suggested.

They proceeded to rent a room in a random hotel for some privacy.

Once they were all seated, Yu Rou began speaking, "Let me tell you about our journey first."

"Sure." Yuan nodded.

Yu Rou talked about their flight, the food they had during the flight, their landing, and their meeting with Grandma Yin and White Lotus. She also talked about their new living quarters and some information about the Eternal Lotuses.

"What do you think, brother? Are you still worried?" Yu Rou asked him afterward.

Yuan smiled and said, "Judging by what you've told me, the Eternal Lotuses does sound like a safe place."

"What about the Yu Family? Have they tried to contact you since you left the family?"

Yu Rou shook her head, "No, they haven't contacted me just yet. Maybe they still don't know about my departure. Or they know but don't care enough to contact me."

"I think it's better if they don't contact you." Yuan then said.

"I think so too." Yu Rou chuckled.

"What about you, brother? How have things been since the contest?"

"Well... We've been receiving a lot of emails since then. In fact, we even got one from the Yu Family. We haven't read any of them, but we can imagine what they want from us." Yuan said.

"That's only to be expected with your level of performance. It will only become worse, you know?" Yu Rou said.

"Yes, I know."

After talking to each other for some time, Yu Rou asked, "Brother, what surprises do you have for me? I think I have been patient enough."

Yuan smiled and said, "Honestly, I wanted to save this surprise until you're ready to use it, or at least during a more proper setting."

He then retrieved a beautiful fan from his storage ring and offered it to her.

"Here. It's an upgrade to your current weapon. It's called the Dragon Fan, and it's an Earth-grade treasure."

Yuan finally handed Yu Rou the treasure he'd gotten from the Dragon Essence Temple.

Yu Rou accepted the beautiful fan with a speechless expression on her face.

"T-Thank you..." Yu Rou muttered after a long moment of silence.

"It's nothing much, but I hope you like it."

Yu Rou then jumped off her seat and into Yuan's embrace.

"Thank you, brother! I will definitely treasure this fan— as well as the old one! Forever!" Yu Rou said in an excited voice.

Yuan then turned to look at Xia Jingyi with an apologetic smile on his face, "I'm sorry, but I don't have a gift for you now. However, I will definitely find one for you in the future."

Xia Jingyi shook her hand and her head at the same time and said, "It's okay, you don't need to worry about me. I don't deserve any gift, anyways."

"That's not true. I will be relying on you to make sure that Yu Rou doesn't get herself into any trouble, so it's only natural I pay you back."

"I won't get into any trouble!" Yu Rou refuted.

"Sure, sure..." Yuan laughed.

They proceeded to spend a couple of hours just talking to each other since it might be some time before they can see each other again.

"Alright, brother. I have taken up enough of your time. Go get some sleep. You too, Meixiu." Yu Rou suddenly said to them.

Yuan nodded and said, "Remember. If you get into any trouble, let us know."

"And you'll come to rescue me like a prince on a white horse, right? I know, brother." Yu Rou chuckled.

"I am serious, Yu Rou. You're very important to me. I do not wish anything bad to happen to you... or Jingyi." Yuan said with a solemn expression on his face.

"I promise." Yu Rou nodded.

After saying their goodbyes and giving each other a hug, Yu Rou gave Yuan a kiss on the cheeks before they eventually logged off to do their own things.

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Chapter 524 Eternal Lotuses

After logging off, Yuan and Meixiu went to sleep.

Meanwhile, Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi tried to get used to their new living quarters.

Once the sky darkened, someone knocked on their doors.

"Here's your dinner for tonight." A member of the Eternal Lotuses handed them two trays of food.

"Don't worry, this is only for today and tomorrow. You'll get to eat in an actual cafeteria once you become a member." The member then said to them.

After accepting the food, Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi cleared it with haste, as they were getting a little hungry since they haven't eaten since leaving the plane.

The member returned an hour later to collect their empty plates.

That night, Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi fell asleep with ease.

The following morning, some members of the Eternal Lotuses gathered the newcomers and led them to the testing site, where they tested the newcomers their cultivation talents and their body limits.

Although there were almost no requirements to join the Eternal Lotuses besides being a certain cultivation level, the newcomers were required to partake in this exam.

Fortunately for the newcomers, failing the exams didn't mean they'll be barred from joining the faction, but it meant that they'll have to put in more effort than the others, as they'll be training separately from the others.

The examination took nearly the entire day, and at the end of the day, Bai Lianhua reappeared before them with the results in the form of a piece of paper.

"There are many ranks within the Eternal Lotuses. From the lowest to the highest— Green Lotus, Blue Lotus, Yellow Lotus, Red Lotus, and lastly, Violet Lotus. If you'd acquired above 80 points in the examination, you'll start out as a Blue Lotus. If you scored below 80 points, you will start at the lowest, Green Lotus."

"There really isn't much of a difference between each rank between the Green Lotus and the Yellow Lotus, so you don't have to worry about being treated differently. The only thing different about each rank will be your training schedule. Everyone will receive fair treatment, meaning that regardless of your rank, you'll receive the same support as your fellow sisters who may have a lower or higher rank."

"However, that doesn't mean you can ignore seniority within the ranks. And in order to incentivize you to increase your position within the faction, I will be allowing those who reach the rank of Red Lotus to train a Heaven-rank cultivation technique and those who reach Violet Lotus to learn a Divine-rank cultivation technique— the same one that I am currently cultivating."

The newcomers were shocked to learn this information, as they weren't aware that someone else besides Player Yuan had acquired a Divine-rank cultivation technique.

After all, the world announcement only lets the players know of the first person to obtain a certain rank and not the others, so unless one announced it, nobody would know about it.

"As for everyone else, you will be allowed to cultivate using an Earth-rank cultivation technique. Of course, this isn't mandatory. If you're satisfied

with your current cultivation technique, you may continue cultivating with it." Bai Lianhua said to them.

And she continued, "Now allow me to talk about the rules."

"There are very few rules within the Eternal Lotuses compared to the other factions, but we take these rules very seriously."

"One, you are not allowed to harm another member in any way unless you're both sparring against each other during an official match or during practice. Depending on the severity, you will be demoted or receive fewer resources for a certain amount of time. If severe enough, we might even kick you out of the faction."

"Two, you are not to leak any information you learn from this place outside. What happens inside this place stays inside. Once again, depending on the severity and information you leaked, you will be punished accordingly."

"Three, you will not do anything that will harm or tarnish the faction's reputation. Depending on the situation, we'll punish you accordingly."

"Four, you will listen to your seniors' orders as long as it's a lawful order."

"Last but not least, you will not betray the faction or any of its members in any fashion. If you're caught doing so... getting kicked out of the faction will be the least of your worries."

"That's all I have for you. You will learn more about the faction and its members as you live with us. Training begins tomorrow morning after breakfast which starts at sunrise and ends 2 hours later."

"Goodnight, Senior Bai!" The new members said to her.

After Bai Lianhua left the scene, one of the members wearing a uniform with red lotuses on it said to them, "Before you all retire for the night, you need to receive your uniforms."

"If you've scored above 80 points today, stand on the right, and if you've scored below, stand on the left."

Yu Rou then made her way to the right side whilst Xia Jingyi, who missed 80 points by only 3 points, stood on the left.

Once everyone was in line, they followed the Red Lotus member to receive their uniforms.

Every member received three pairs of uniforms.

"You only really need two pairs of uniforms since you'll have your uniforms washed every day, but just in case you destroy one, you're given a third. If you're ever down to just two uniforms, ask for another one."

"Also, Senior Sister Bai didn't mention this, but if you intend on leaving the faction for whatever reason, you must speak with her before you're allowed to do so. Though I don't understand why anyone would want to leave this paradise."

"If you cannot tell already, compared to the other factions, we're quite lenient and very fair towards our members as long as they don't do anything stupid."

"However, don't take advantage of Senior Sister Bai's kindness, because if you anger her... Let's just say you don't want to see her angry."

Sometime later, Yu Rou and the others returned to their rooms with their new uniforms.

After a quick shower and dinner, they went to sleep and prepared themselves for training tomorrow.

Chapter 525 Once a Week

Early in the morning before sunrise, Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi left their rooms after washing their face.

Yu Rou was already used to waking up this early in the morning as a Yuan's caretaker, so she wasn't bothered by it.

Xia Jingyi, however, had struggled to wake up. If it wasn't for Yu Rou, who pulled her blanket from her bed, she wouldn't have woken up.

"Thank you for waking me up, Sister Rou... It's only the first day of training and I am already troubling you..." Xia Jingyi sighed as they made their way to the cafeteria.

"Don't mention it."

A few minutes later, they arrived before a 4-story tall building that was the size of a mini-mall.

"T-This is the cafeteria...?" Xia Jingyi looked up at the building with a dazed look on her face.

Yu Rou looked at the map given to them last night and nodded, "This should be the right place."

"Look, there are plenty others coming to this place. We are definitely in the right place." Yu Rou added.

"This place is just a small city in the middle of the wilderness... I wonder how long did it take them to build this place..." Xia Jingyi wondered out loud.

"Probably not long based on what Grandma Yin told us about this place."

"Anyways, let's go inside and see what they have."

The two of them entered the building a few moments later, and to their surprise, there were food stores on every single floor with at least 6 unique stores and restaurants on each floor.

"I was just thinking to myself how life will be for us when the nearest city is 3 hours away. I guess this answers it." Yu Rou mumbled in a low voice.

With this many restaurants and variety of foods, they definitely won't get bored of the food here anytime soon.

"If the other places are anything like this, I wouldn't mind living here forever," Xia Jingyi said.

The two of them proceeded to spend a couple of minutes looking for a restaurant to eat at.

They finished eating in half an hour and used their remaining time to look around the place.

Once it was almost time for training, Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi went separate ways since they were of different ranks, meaning they trained differently.

Meanwhile, 8,000 miles away inside Yuan's apartment, Yuan just finished his daily routine and prepared to wash himself.

"Yuan, are you sure you don't need any help? How are you washing your back?" Meixiu asked him before he entered the bathroom.

"Uh... It's a little difficult, but I can manage," he said.

"You know you don't have to do everything yourself. I know you want to rely on yourself now that you can finally move, but you should rely on others as well. At this rate, I will have nothing else to do besides cooking and cleaning the apartment, but who knows when you'll take that away from me too." Meixiu said in a sighing voice.

Yuan stopped to ponder for a moment.

"I am still technically your caretaker, Yuan. Let me assist you like I was trained. You can do everything else yourself. After all, I don't want to feel like I'd trained for nothing..."

Hearing her words, Yuan said to her, "Sorry, I haven't taken your feelings into consideration. Can you please help me wash my back?"

"Of course." Meixiu quickly responded.

They entered the bathroom together a few moments later.

"Take a seat," Meixiu said to him.

Yuan nodded and sat on a small bathroom chair.

Meixiu then rinsed his body with water before rubbing his back with her soapy hands.

Once his back was covered in soap, Meixiu asked him, "Shall I wash the front too?"

"If you don't mind," he said.

"I don't," she responded and walked to the front before squatting down.

A moment later, she started rubbing her soft hands on his refined body.

Starting from the top then moving straight to his legs, Meixiu washed every inch of his body.

Once there was only a single area left, Meixiu cleared her throat and asked, "D-Do you want me to wash that part too?"

Meixiu expected Yuan to refuse, but to her surprise, Yuan repeated, "If you don't mind."

Meixiu took a deep breath and started washing his cute snake.

However, that cute snake quickly woke up and turned into a ferocious dragon.

Seeing this, Meixiu asked him, "H-Have you relieved this part recently?"

"To tell you the truth, I have tried to do it by myself, even mimicking your movements, but I can't get it to work. It just doesn't feel the same," he said in a sighing voice.

"I understand... Then allow me to do it for you. And don't you dare use divine sense while I am doing this..." Meixiu said in a bashful voice, and she began relieving him.

Yuan's body quickly started trembling with delight from Meixiu's skillful techniques, feeling a certain sensation that he couldn't replicate by himself for some reason.

A few minutes later, Yuan released his stress all over the floor.

"According to my research, a man should relieve himself at least daily, which comes with certain health benefits. If you want, I can help you every day." Meixiu said to him as she washed the sticky white stuff away with the showerhead.

"E-Every day...?" Yuan hesitated this time.

"If that's too much, we can do it once every other day— or even once a week," she said.

"Once a week sounds good enough."

"I understand. Then in addition to washing your body, I will help you relieve your stress once a week." Meixiu said.

"Okay, but you don't have to help wash my body every time I want to rinse my body after sweating from my exercise."

"Then I will help you whenever you take your last shower for the day."

"Okay," he nodded in agreement.

And thus, their life continued in this manner for the next two weeks, with Yuan spending most of his day training his body while Meixiu cultivated normally and did the housework.

Before they were aware, it has been almost a month since Yuan visited the Cultivators' Association, meaning that it was about time for him to visit the Spirit Masters he'd met at that time to learn more about cultivation and their history.

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Chapter 526 Taking the Airplane

"You want to go like this?" Meixiu spoke as she watched Yuan retrieve his wheelchair before sitting on it.

"Yes, I will disguise myself once I arrive at that place," he nodded.

"I guess that makes sense."

"Will you be able to carry the luggage as well?" Yuan then asked.

"Yes, I will be fine," Meixiu responded in a calm voice as she carried a massive backpack on her back that looked incredibly heavy.

Despite its frightening appearance, the backpack mostly had clothes and some other light objects, so it wasn't actually that heavy— not that it would matter to Meixiu, who could lift a car with her bare hands and without breaking a sweat.

Since they don't know when they'll return, Meixiu packed a little more clothes than usual.

Of course, if they needed anything, they had plenty of money to buy them.

Once they were prepared, Meixiu left the apartment with Yuan and took a taxi to the airport.

Meixiu showed their tickets that had been purchased beforehand to the worker at the airport.

"F-First-class..."

The worker was surprised to see two youngsters riding first-class that would normally cost tens of thousands of dollars.

Meixiu then handed her large backpack to the worker so that they could put it on the plane for them.

After checking in, Meixiu took Yuan to the terminal with their flight.

"The flight should be here in an hour," she said to Yuan after sitting down.

"Okay."

Time passed slower than usual while they waited for the plane, but it eventually arrived, and they were the first onboard due to their first-class ticket.

Normally, if one were to ride commercial or even business-class, they would only get seats, but for Yuan and Meixiu flying first-class, they got a whole room to themselves. The room didn't have much space, but it had a bed and a bathroom. Of course, the most important thing was their privacy, as they didn't have to deal with the other passengers.

Once they entered their room, Yuan stood up from his wheelchair and stretched his body.

"It's been a while since I last sat in that position for so long... My body is feeling stiff from it." He sighed.

"How long is the flight again?" Yuan asked Meixiu after taking a seat on the bed.

"26 hours..."

"It's even longer than Yu Rou's flight? Heavens..."

"We can go back home now if you want..." Meixiu said in a slightly joking voice.

"After coming all the way here? I'd rather not."

The plane started moving about half an hour after they boarded it.

During their flight, Yuan would lay on the bed and read the magazines provided by the plane.

Since they were in the air and the plane was quite shaky, it made cultivation very difficult, so they didn't even bother with it.

The flight attendants would knock on their door every few hours to provide them with luxurious food that was expected from first-class.

If they needed anything to drink, they only needed to call the flight attendants back with the press of a button.

Obviously, this wasn't Yuan or Meixiu's first time flying in an airplane, especially Yuan, who was used to flying all around the world to play the instrument for the Yu Family.

Eventually, it was time to sleep, but they encountered a problem— there was only one bed in their room.

Although the bed was more than enough to fit the both of them, this would be their first time actually sharing a bed.

"Are you not going to sleep?" Yuan asked her as he laid on one side of the bed in a casual manner.

"You don't mind sharing the bed?" Meixiu asked.

"Why would I? Or did you expect me to tell you to sleep on the floor?"

"No..."

Meixiu quickly gave up and got onto the bed with him.

Yuan quickly fell asleep, but Meixiu was struggling to do so with Yuan being so close to her.

'Why am I so nervous? Nothing will happen even if we sleep on the same bed, and we have already done things much worse than sharing a bed...'

Meixiu eventually managed to convince herself that it wasn't that much of a deal sharing a bed with Yuan.

However, when she woke up the next day, she would find one of Yuan's hands groping her breast.

Of course, Yuan was still asleep, being completely unaware of his actions.

After her initial shock, Meixiu merely shook her head and gently removed his hands from her chest without making a big deal out of it.

Yuan woke up shortly afterward.

"Good morning, Meixiu," he said to her.

"Good morning," she pretended the accident never happened.

"How long has it been since we left?" Yuan asked.

Meixiu looked at the time and said, "We have another 10 hours."

"I see..."

And for the remainder of the last 10 hours, Yuan would practice his divine sense by using it to look around the airplane until he was exhausted and needed to recover.

Once he recovered, Yuan would use his divine sense and repeat the next steps.

"Hmm? What are they doing inside the bathroom?" Yuan accidentally peeked inside the bathroom and found two passengers— one male and one female— doing some weird stuff in the bathroom that had barely any space.

"What are you talking about?" Meixiu asked him since he spoke out loud just now.

Yuan proceeded to explain what he was witnessing with his divine sense.

Meixiu's face immediately flushed with redness after hearing the details and realizing what Yuan was watching.

"S-Stop watching them! It's rude to intrude on their privacy!" Meixiu quickly said to him.

"Sorry, but I have never seen anything like that before, so I was kind of distracted by it." Yuan retracted his divine sense the next moment, yet the scene he'd just witnessed was still clear inside his head.

Meixiu released a profound sigh afterward, silently hoping to herself that Yuan doesn't ask her for more details about what he'd just witnessed.

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Chapter 527 Helicopter Service

Ding!

"We will be arriving at Yang City in two hours."

An announcer spoke on the speaker shortly after Yuan stopped using his divine sense.

"Only two hours left, huh? I cannot wait." Yuan laid on the bed, feeling like it's been forever since he last breathed fresh air.

And for the last two hours, Yuan decided to order the entire menu available on the airplane and indulged himself in their food.

Two hours later, the plane began descending back to the ground.

Once they landed, Yuan took a seat in the wheelchair and waited until Meixiu pushed him outside.

"Thank you for flying with Royal Airlines." The flight attendants bowed to them as they left the airplane and into Yang City's airport.

Meixiu then led Yuan outside the airport and into the unknown streets before taking a taxi to the Jaded Garden.

"We'd like to go to the Jaded Garden," Meixiu said to the driver after entering the taxi with Yuan, who immediately turned to look at them with a baffled look on his face.

"You want to go to the Jaded Garden?" The man asked her again for confirmation, almost as though he couldn't believe it.

"Yes, is there anything wrong with that?"

The man nodded and said, "You won't be able to enter the Jaded Garden in any vehicle that doesn't fly. Despite its name, it's actually in the middle of a mountain valley 8 hours away from Yang City. I can get you close to that place, but I cannot enter the mountain range."

"Is that so... What should we do?" Meixiu asked Yuan.

Yuan pondered for a moment before speaking, "You said any vehicle that doesn't fly, which means we can take a plane or helicopter there, right? Are there any services that allow us to travel on helicopters?"

"There is one three hours away from this place, but it won't be cheap."

"Can you take us there instead?" Yuan said.

"Sure thing. The fee will be..."

After paying the driver the fee for the trip, the taxi driver immediately stepped on the pedal and began driving them.

About three hours later, they arrived at this tall building with multiple agencies working inside.

"Thanks a bunch."

Once they left the taxi, Meixiu entered the building with Yuan still in the wheelchair.

"Hello, how may I help you?" The receptionist waved at them the moment she noticed them.

Meixiu approached the receptionist and said, "Good morning, I heard there's a helicopter service here?"

"Yes, that's correct. Where are you trying to go?"

"Jade Garden."

"Jaded Garden, huh? It's not that far away, but due to the high terrains and foggy environment in that place that makes it difficult to traverse even in the air, the price will increase exponentially. If you're okay with that, please fill out this piece of paper and we'll get to you."

Meixiu took the paper and looked at its contents that asked for their basic information.

"What should I do? Should I use an alias?" Meixiu asked Yuan for advice.

"I think you can use my real identity since I am basically a nobody here," Yuan said.

"Okay."

Meixiu then filled out the paper using Yu Tian's identity that has long been forgotten. Furthermore, even if they somehow link Yuan to Yu Tian, they won't be able to find him unless they speak with the Yu Family or those that know his identity.

"Here you go." Meixiu handed the paper back to the receptionist after filling it out.

"Thank you. Please give me a minute to calculate the price of the trip. Also, will this be a one-way or a round trip? If you choose a round trip, we will land and stay at a certain location until you return. However, you'll have to pay a certain fee for every single day we wait."

"We'll do a round trip. If we no longer need the service, can we cancel the round trip?" Meixiu asked.

"Of course, but you'll still have to pay the fee depending on how many days you made the pilot wait regardless if you return or not."

"That sounds good." Meixiu nodded.

The receptionist then took a couple of minutes to calculate the cost.

"The total amount will cost 50,000 dollars for a round trip, not including the waiting time. The waiting fee will be 1,000 dollars for every 24 hours we wait at that location."

"Here."

Meixiu placed their debit card on the desk without any hesitation despite the ride costing a whopping 50 thousand dollars.

Clearly, that amount of money wasn't enough to make her even raise an eyebrow.

The receptionist gladly accepted their card and charged them 50,000 dollars.

"I have notified the pilot of your ride. It should be ready within 2 hours. Please wait in the guest room until then. It's that room over there." The receptionist pointed to the room at the end of the hall.

Meixiu and Yuan proceeded to wait inside the guest room until their ride was ready.

A little over two hours later, the receptionist knocked on the door before entering their room with a blonde middle-aged man wearing a uniform.

"Hello, esteemed guests. Your ride is ready, and he will be your pilot."

The middle-aged man greeted them with a smile on his face, "My name is Jean. I have over 20 years of experience, and I have traveled to the Jaded Garden over 100 times in my career without a single accident, so you can rely on me."

Meixiu and Yuan then followed the pilot to the back of the building, where there was a large empty field alongside a couple of helicopters idling inside a hanger.

The helicopter they were going to ride was already prepared and was waiting for them to board in the middle of the track.

After boarding the helicopter, the pilot took a few minutes to explain some rules to them.

"Do you guys have experience with helicopters?" Jean asked them after explaining the rules.

"Yes, we do." Meixiu nodded.

"I figured. Then let's go. We should arrive at the Jaded Garden in an hour." Jean said as he operated the helicopter, taking them into the air.

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Chapter 528 Jaded Garden

"Mister, you mentioned that you'd traveled to the Jaded Garden multiple times, right? Do you know the families that live there such as the Wang Family? Can you tell us a little about that place as well?" Yuan asked the pilot as they traveled in the air.

"Of course. The Jaded Garden is a unique place that's home to the Six Spiritual Families, and the Wang Family is one of these families. The Six Spirit Families is an alliance of sorts between 6 separate powerful families, but not much is known about them, as they have only revealed themselves recently, quickly becoming powerhouses within the cultivation world."

"In fact, the Jaded Garden used to be a secluded area, but ever since cultivation became known to the world, they began opening their doors to outsiders, even taking some people in as disciples."

"Is this why you're traveling to that place?" Jean asked them.

"Something like that." Yuan nodded.

"Well, good luck. It won't be easy joining their faction. From what I've heard, they have many cultivation geniuses that have already reached Spirit Warrior within their background, but I don't know whether that information is true or fake, and it's quite hard to believe that there are already people that have reached Spirit Warrior."

"Many Spirit Warriors..." Yuan mumbled.

If they'd known about cultivation for hundreds of years now, it wouldn't be weird if they had Spirit Warriors, and even Spirit Master was possible as they'd already proved to him.

In fact, it would be weird if they didn't.

About half an hour later, they arrived before a mountain valley that was enveloped in thick fog.

"Can you even navigate inside such a thick fog?" Meixiu asked when she saw the fog in the distance.

"Yes, it'll be fine. It's only foggy at the entrance and high altitudes which we must travel because of the tall mountains. Once we pass the mountain, we can start to descend into the valley where there isn't as fog."

"As for the navigating through the fog, we have an autopilot system prepared just for this, allowing the helicopter to autopilot itself through the fog at a predetermined path," Jean explained to them.

"I see..." Meixiu nodded.

And just like he'd said, Jean made the helicopter go into autopiloting mode once they reached the fog.

After another half an hour, they could feel the helicopter descending towards the ground.

A few moments later, their helicopter emerged from the fog and entered a vast but clear plain in the middle of a mountain valley.

"We have safely entered the Jaded Garden. We will arrive at the landing site in 10 minutes." Jean said to them as he regained control over the helicopter.

Although he could've continued to let the helicopter fly on autopilot, he enjoyed controlling the helicopter personally.

Ten minutes later, the helicopter landed in a spacious land that had a couple of helicopters that belonged to others parked.

"Here's my phone number. Call me if you need anything." Jean handed Meixiu a business card that had his name and phone number.

"Also, I can only stay here for 30 days maximum before I have to return to the agency. If you stay longer than that but still wish to return with me, you'll have to purchase another ride with the agency including the waiting fee." Jean warned them.

"As for where I will stay..."

Jean pointed to a building a few hundred meters in the distance and said, "I will be there if you cannot call me for any reason."

"I understand." Meixiu nodded.

Before they left, Yuan asked Jean, "Mister, can I leave my wheelchair here in the helicopter?"

"Eh? I don't mind..." Jean nodded his head, but he was definitely taken by surprise by Yuan's question.

After all, why would someone who had to travel in a wheelchair leave it behind? Does he intend on letting the young lady carry him the whole time?

"Thanks." Yuan then stood up from the wheelchair without any effort before folding it and putting it inside the helicopter, leaving Jean dumbfounded.

"By the way, which direction do we go?" Meixiu then asked, as she couldn't see any cities or buildings beside the one Jean pointed to in the area.

"It's three miles that way." Jean pointed in a certain direction, and he continued, "Unfortunately, there are no taxi services in this area, so you'll have to walk there."

"That's fine. Let's go." Yuan said.

Meixiu and Yuan then quickly left the scene, and since they weren't in a hurry, they walked very slowly, quietly enjoying the environment and fresh air.

"I have never smelt such fresh air before," Yuan said after he took a few deep breaths.

"Yes, this place has very clean and high-quality air. Every single breath I take makes me feel cleaner inside." Meixiu agreed with him.

After walking for an hour, Meixiu could finally see some tall buildings in the distance.

"We're almost there," she said to Yuan since he couldn't see that far with his divine sense.

"Here you go." She then handed Yuan his black mask before wearing one herself.

A couple more minutes later, they arrived before a large gate where a few guards stood.

"Hmm?"

The guards quickly noticed their presence, and one of them said, "That person is wearing a black mask. Do you think he's the person Senior Wang warned us about? What was his name again?"

"His name is Yuan," said another.

They were clearly instructed to be on the lookout for a person wearing a mask.

Sometime later, Yuan and Meixiu finally arrived before these guards.

"Hello, is there a 'Yuan' amongst you two?" One of the guards asked them.

"That's right. I am Yuan." Yuan responded in a calm voice.

"I understand. Please wait for a minute. We have already sent someone to notify Senior Wang. She should be here shortly."

"Okay." Yuan nodded, and they proceeded to wait some more until the guard that left to find Senior Wang returned to the site with her beside him.

Chapter 529 Spiritual Elites

"Thank you for taking your time to come to our Jaded Garden, Yuan."
Senior Wang bowed to him in a respectful manner despite their difference in age.

In the world of cultivation, one's strength and ability were more valued than one's age, so one must respect the other if they were stronger regardless of their ages.

If it weren't for the fact that they were at the same cultivation level, she would've addressed Yuan as 'Senior Yuan'.

The guards didn't know that Yuan was also a Spirit Master like Senior Wang, so her actions left them dumbfounded for a good moment, as they have never seen her act so respectful towards a junior.

"I am here because I want to know more about cultivation... and your background," Yuan spoke in a calm voice.

"Of course. That's why we requested for your presence." Senior Wang nodded.

"Please, follow me."

They then followed Senior Wang inside the gates.

"The others aren't aware of your presence yet, so allow us some time to prepare." Senior Wang said to them as they walked.

"What is this place?" Yuan asked her.

Although he learned a little about the Jaded Garden from the pilot, he wanted to hear about it from someone who lives here.

"The Jaded Garden is a special place created by the Six Spiritual Families where our branches live in harmony as proof of our alliance. However, that isn't the main reason we created this place."

"The Jaded Garden is actually a training spot for the Six Spiritual Families where we send our juniors to learn about cultivation and become cultivators. It used to be a secluded area for many centuries, but now that cultivation is known to the entire world, we decided to open up this place and use it as the headquarters for our new cultivation faction known as the Spiritual Elites."

"Spiritual Elites..." Yuan repeated in a muttering voice.

And he asked, "What are the requirements to join the faction?"

Senior Wang smiled and said, "Are you interested? If you want to join, we'll accept you right away."

"That wasn't my intention." Yuan quickly responded.

"Too bad. Maybe we can change your mind later. Anyways, we only have 2 requirements for those who want to join our faction. One, you must be under the age of 21. And lastly, you must be at the very least at the eighth level of Spirit Apprentice."

"Eighth level Spirit Apprentice below the age of 21? So everyone above the age of 21 will be automatically disqualified regardless of their cultivation levels? That isn't very fair since the majority of people in this world have only started cultivating a couple of months ago." Meixiu said.

"That is correct, as we only want young people with potential. Even if you're extremely talented, if you start cultivating at the age of 21, you will not achieve as much as someone who has inferior talents but started cultivating at a much younger age." Senior Wang responded.

And she continued, "For example, between two individuals— one who started cultivating at the age of 10 and one who started at the age of 21—the person who started at the age of 10 will have 11 years of experience by the time he's 21 and will generally achieve more in his life than the person who started at 21 years old."

"One might argue that the gap doesn't really matter if the person who started cultivating at the age of 21 had immense talents that allowed him to ignore his setback, but these people are too few and far in-between. However, if someone like that does exist, we could simply make an exception for them."

Senior Wang's gaze glanced at Yuan for a brief moment when she said that sentence.

"By the way, this place has existed for over 500 years."

"500 years...? Just how long have you guys known about cultivation?" Yuan couldn't help but ask.

"I can't tell you the exact date since we also don't know, but let's just say we've known about cultivation since we can remember." Senior Wang said.

"I see... What's the highest cultivation someone has achieved?" Yuan then asked.

"Spirit Master," she quickly responded.

"Even the most talented genius within the Six Spiritual Families has only achieved the 3rd level Spirit Master before he perished. I don't think it's possible to reach any higher due to the lack of Qi in this world and a lack of good techniques."

"The existence of Cultivation Online might change that since we'll be able to acquire better cultivation techniques, but that won't fix the issue with the lack of Qi."

"Anyways, we are here. Please wait a bit for me to gather the others." Senior Wang said as they arrived before a large pond that had a couple of buildings built on top of the water.

This reminded Yuan of the Dragon Pavilion inside the Dragon Essence Temple.

Senior Wang then led Yuan and Meixiu to the largest pavilion there.

Once Yuan and Meixiu sat down around a large round table made of marble, Senior Wang said, "I will now gather the others."

Senior Wang left the scene shortly after, leaving the two of them alone in this place.

"What do you think?" Yuan suddenly asked.

"What do you mean?"

"What do you think of this place and Senior Wang? Can we trust them?"

Meixiu pondered for a moment before speaking, "I don't know, that Senior Wang seemed pretty respectful and friendly, but we can never be too careful."

Yuan nodded and said, "I think so too. Anyways, while I am 'Yuan', I will be acting a little different than usual to not give away my identity and to make sure they take me seriously, and I kind of gave myself a serious and unfriendly image at the Cultivators' Association."

"I kind of figured since you felt a little different than normal since we have arrived at this place," Meixiu said.

And she added, "I will also try to act differently."

About fifteen minutes later, Senior Wang returned to the lake with five other individuals— all of them with an elderly appearance.

Chapter 530 Six Spiritual Families

"That's Player Yuan? What an unfathomable aura... I can feel it even this far away..." One of the seniors there spoke in a low voice as they approached the lake.

"I didn't believe when you told me that he was a Spirit Master, but now that I am seeing him personally... heavens..."

"Do you think he's from a secluded family? I don't want to believe that he'd managed to achieve that level after Cultivation Online was introduced..." Another one said.

"We'll find out in just a moment."

A few moments later, Senior Wang and the five seniors stood in front of Yuan and Meixiu on the other side of the table, and they started introducing themselves.

"Once again, I am surnamed Wang from the Wang Family, from one of the Six Spiritual Families, and I am a Grand Elder."

"I am surnamed Wu from the Wu Family. I believe we have met at the Cultivators' Association as well."

"Surnamed Zhi, and we have also met at the Cultivators' Association."

"My surname is Li."

"Surnamed Xi."

"And my surname is Hong."

Yuan stood up and said in a calm voice, "My name is Yuan, and this is my caretaker."

Meixiu stood up and said, "Surnamed Feng."

Since Yuan gave himself an alias, Meixiu decided to do the same, especially since her recent incident that made her name public, and she picked Feng Yuxiang's surname as her alias.

"Allow us to welcome you to the Jaded Garden once again, Yuan. Whether you believe it or not, your presence here means a great deal to us." Senior Wang said to him with a respectful bow by clasping her hands together.

The other elders did the same.

A moment later, they all sat around the marble table.

"There's a lot to talk about, but let us start with our background." Senior Wang said.

And she continued, "The Six Spiritual Families have existed for thousands of years, but we were not always this peaceful with each other. In fact, we used to be at war with each other until 300 years ago."

Senior Wu then continued, "However, there was one thing we all agreed upon even during our times of war, and that was to keep the existence of cultivation a secret."

"Thus, we have managed to keep cultivation a secret from the public while silently cultivating ourselves."

Senior Zhi then said, "That's the purpose of this place— to train our juniors together. It's like a sect— the same ones you see in Cultivation Online, but we're much smaller. If you'd like, we can even show you around the place afterward."

"I'd like that," Yuan said, as he was curious what a modern-day sect would look like and how it compared to the sects within Cultivation Online.

The elders continued to spend a couple more minutes talking about their families' history before one of them asked, "Yuan, can you tell us a little more about yourself? If you want to keep your identity hidden, that's perfectly fine. What about your cultivation level? When did you start cultivating?"

He nodded and said, "As you already know, I am a Spirit Master, but I only recently achieved this level. As for how long I have been cultivating... shortly after I began playing Cultivation Online, I guess."

"Aiya..."

The elders there suddenly released stressful sighs, and all of them held a defeated expression on their faces for some reason.

"I was hoping you'd started cultivating many years ago so we don't look as bad before your talents, but alas, you have managed to achieve Spirit Master in less than a year while it took all of us over 100 years to reach Spirit Master. The difference is like heaven and hell... No, it's incomparable..." One of the elders there expressed his distress.

"Why is there such injustice under this heavens?" Another sighed.

After a few moments of contemplating their lives, the elders eventually gave up and said, "Do you want to take a look around the place?"

"Sure," he nodded.

Although the elders wanted to ask more questions about him, they didn't dare to ask them, as they were afraid of offending him.

After all, it was clear to them that Yuan wanted to keep his identity a secret, and as people who have kept cultivation from the world for centuries, they knew very well what Yuan was feeling and his thoughts, so they purposefully avoided asking him questions that could reveal his identity.

Furthermore, they believed that if they earned his trust, there was a good chance that he would reveal his identity willingly. Until then, they will have

to approach him with caution.

Yuan's talent that allowed him to reach Spirit Master in less than a year was something incomprehensible for these elders that used to be the top genius within their generation.

"What do you think of the cultivation world this far?" Senior Wang asked him as they walked around him like a group of grandparents and their grandchildren.

"Although it has its flaws, I genuinely enjoy the cultivation world within Cultivation Online, but whether cultivation is a good thing or a bad thing for this world... I still don't know yet," he calmly responded.

"I agree. Everything was fine before since there were only very few of us that knew about cultivation if you consider the world's population, but now that everyone is aware of cultivation... I fear what might happen in the future."

"This is also why we opened up the Jaded Garden to the public to attract talents— because we fear the future and want to prepare ourselves before it's too late."

"What do you mean?" Yuan asked her, his interest piqued.

"You see, inside an ancient scroll left behind by our ancestors, there is a prophecy— that when the world starts cultivation, there will be a calamity."

"A calamity?" Yuan raised his eyebrows behind the mask, as did Meixiu.

"Yes, a calamity will befall upon this world, propelling this world into chaos." Senior Wang said in a sighing voice.

"This is another reason why we decided to keep cultivation a secret from the world. If you want, I can show you the scroll after the tour."

"Okay," he quickly said.

Chapter 531 Underrated

"Hey, look! It's the Grand Elders! Who are those two masked individuals with them?" The people there quickly took notice of their presence, as the Grand Elders were incredibly influential and powerful people there.

"I have never seen them before."

"Me neither."

"They must be very important if they are being guided by the Grand Elders..."

While the disciples there tried to guess the identity of these two masked individuals, the Grand Elders led Yuan and Meixiu around the Jaded Garden.

"This right here is the training hall."

They first stopped before a large building and explained, "This is where the disciples are lectured and taught how to wield their weapons and cultivate. In other words, it's where they are taught how to fight."

"Although we don't really use our combat experience in the outside world, we often spar with each other so that we won't be powerless when we need to fight."

"It is also one of the most populated places in the entire Jaded Garden due to its purposes."

The Grand Elders then led Yuan and Meixiu inside this building that had many floors.

"The first and second floor is dedicated to disciples who wish to learn the sword."

Senior Wang said as she opened the door to a spacious gymnasium where hundreds of disciples could be seen practicing their sword techniques.

"The sword is the most popular weapon for cultivators due to its ease of use and its destructive prowess. That's why we have two entire floors dedicated to the sword."

Yuan used his divine sense to watch a few of these disciples practicing their sword techniques.

Then he noticed something— that their swords were enveloped by a thin layer of spiritual energy.

"They're using sword techniques...? Are these techniques from Cultivation Online or something from your families?" Yuan decided to ask them.

"These sword techniques came from Wu Family since it's their specialty," said Senior Wang.

"I see..."

"If you'd like to learn the technique, you can join our faction and we'll let you learn as many techniques as you want, and we have over 20 different techniques combined," she said with a smile on her face.

"I will consider it," he said.

Sometime later, they skipped the second floor since it was the same as the first floor and went straight to the third floor.

"This floor is dedicated to disciples who wish to learn the spear and polearm— basically long-ranged melee weapons. The Shi family and Xi Family are in charge of this floor since they're both experts with long-range weapons."

Yuan silently watched the disciples practice this unfamiliar weapon for the next few minutes, as he has only fought very few opponents who used spears and polearms.

The most notable fight he had with a long-range weapon was within the Ancient Dragon City when he had to fight many experts.

Ten minutes later, they went to the fourth floor.

"This floor is dedicated to archery. It's a unique and underrated weapon in the cultivation world, and in our modern world, they are usually used as a sport."

"A bow, huh? Now that you mention it... I don't think I have ever seen a bow wielder inside Cultivation Online. Why do you think they are so underrated?" Yuan asked her.

"Well, for one, you have to aim using the bow, and people would rather use something more convenient, such as swords since you only need to swing it."

"Secondly, it requires much more skills and training to fully master the bow."

"Third, in the cultivation world where most people fight close-quarters, you won't be able to use the bow efficiently unless you gain distance from your opponent, which is easier said than done."

"There are more reasons why people don't use the bow, but these are the main reasons."

"However, even if the weapon is underrated, it is by no means weak. Once you put the time to master the bow and how to fight with it, it could become an unstoppable weapon, and it would only become even more powerful if you have a partner that can protect you while you fight in the back."

"The bow can quickly become a nuisance and untouchable in the right situation and the right hands."

Meixiu silently listened to Senior Wang talk about the bow. Although she'd intended on using her bare hands in Cultivation Online, she was starting to have thought about using the bow, as this will allow her to support Yuan from the rear without getting in his way.

And with Yuan in front of her, she was confident that nobody will be able to get to her while she abuses their opponents from a distance.

However, there was one issue, and that was she didn't have any experience with the bow.

Although she has plenty of experience with a gun, she had zero when it comes to the bow.

Twang!

The sound of strings trembling would constantly resound in the room as a little under one hundred disciples practiced their aiming skills on their targets.

A couple of minutes later, they made their way to the fifth floor.

"The fifth and sixth floor is the last two floors to this tower, and they are both dedicated to cultivation since the bottom floors are usually the loudest. We also have private cultivation rooms that are completely soundproof just in case."

"There isn't anything fancy like formations in this place, but this is place is mostly for ordinary disciples. Elite disciples and us elders usually cultivate at the Immortal Caves, where the spiritual energy is much denser."

"There are Immortal Caves in this world?" Yuan was truly surprised to hear this.

"Do you want to see them later?" Senior Wang asked him with a profound glint in her gaze.

She knew that this could potentially convince him to join their faction.

"Of course," he quickly nodded.

"Then let's make our way to the sparring area. It's on the way to the Immortal Caves." Senior Wang said, and they left the building shortly after.

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Chapter 532 A Friendly Exchange

After leaving the training area, the Grand Elders led Yuan and Meixiu to the sparring area that was an open field with multiple stages available, and there was even a spectators' area.

When they arrived at the sparring area, they could see a couple of disciples sparring with each other on the stages, but all of them were fighting without any weapons.

"Most disciples come here for training and experience, but it's also very common for disciples with grievances to come here to release their stress or simply to 'settle things'. Although they get out of hand sometimes, killing or serious injuries that could cripple another are not allowed, or they will be crippled and be forced to work as a servant in one of the Six Spiritual Families." Senior Shi explained to them.

"Of course, since we risk them revealing the existence of cultivation to the world, we cannot allow them to simply leave the family, so they can either choose to work as a servant or be killed."

"To be a servant or to be killed..." Yuan mumbled in a low voice.

Then he asked, "Others can also leak this information, so does this mean that disciples are not allowed to communicate with the outside world?"

"You are correct. Most of us live a secluded lifestyle, and when we go outside, we are only allowed to communicate with the other cultivation families. Though, trusted individuals and high-ranking elders such as ourselves are allowed to communicate with the mortal world."

Yuan sighed inwardly after learning about their secluded lifestyle. He couldn't imagine living such a boring life, where you can only

communicate with those around you, but fortunately for them, they had other families to keep each other companied.

However, compared to the majority of his life, where he was secluded within his own room for many years with barely any interaction with others, it was still much better.

After watching the disciples spar for a couple of minutes, one of the grand elders suddenly said, "Fellow Daoist Yuan, if it isn't too much to ask, can I request for a friendly exchange with you?"

Yuan turned to look at the old man who just asked this question and said in a calm voice, "You want to spar with me?"

"Yes." The old man confirmed.

"You can't be serious right now, Elder Xi." Senior Wang said with a slight frown on her face.

"I don't mind," Yuan suddenly said.

He then continued, "However, I will only be dodging your attacks, if you don't mind."

"Only dodging?" Elder Xi raised his eyebrows in a puzzled manner.

"Yes, you can attack me as you like, and if you manage to hit me even once, I will consider it my loss." Yuan nodded.

There were a few reasons as to why Yuan made this suggestion, but the biggest reason as to why he would only be dodging is simply because he has zero experience in fighting in his current body.

Although he has plenty of experience in Cultivation Online, things were different in this world, and he didn't have his sword with him.

Furthermore, he wanted to test out the movement technique that he'd been practicing for the past month and see how effective it was against the top cultivators of this world.

"Good luck, Yuan," Meixiu said to him before they entered the stage.

Elder Xi's presence quickly attracted everyone's attention within the sparring area.

"Look! Elder Xi is going onto the stage! Is he going to spar with that masked person?!"

"Who is that individual?! Does anyone know?!"

The people there quickly surrounded the stage with Elder Xi and Yuan.

"Whenever you're ready." Elder Xi said to Yuan as they stood a couple of meters away from each other.

"Attack me whenever you're ready." Yuan then said.

"Then here I come!"

Elder Xi immediately rushed forward with incredible speed, arriving before Yuan a second later.

However, Yuan remained standing there without moving a single muscle.

The spectators thought that was because he couldn't react to Elder Xi's speed, but they quickly realized how wrong they were when Yuan barely dodged Elder Xi's attack right before the strike landed.

Elder Xi wasn't too surprised that his attack had been avoided since he was just testing Yuan, so he continued to throw his hands at Yuan, using basic martial arts.

'This guy... What a fearsome movement technique!'

Elder Xi soon realized that Yuan would always barely avoid his attacks, meaning that Yuan was purposefully minimizing his movements to dodge flawless while saving himself energy at the same time.

"Wow! Look at that masked person's movements! They are so profound! I have never seen anything like that before!"

"Heavens! Where did he learn such a technique?!"

This continued for over half an hour with Elder Xi being unable to touch even Yuan's clothes, much less the person himself.

Elder Xi eventually stopped moving and said, "I give up... You win this one, fellow Daoist Yuan."

"What! Did Elder Xi just called him 'Yuan'?!"

"Could he be that famous Player Yuan?! What's he doing here?!"

When the spectators heard Elder Xi addressing Yuan by his name, they all expressed great shock.

However, if they thought about it, it made sense since only Player Yuan could possibly be powerful enough to defeat their grand elder.

"You have me completely beaten without attacking me. I cannot imagine winning if you're allowed to attack." Elder Xi bowed to him afterward, not feeling bitter despite losing since he was well aware of their disparity.

"Thank you for the spar as well; it was a good experience." Yuan copied his movements and returned the bow.

The other grand elders were speechless. Although Elder Xi and Yuan were both Spirit Masters, one had decades more experience than the other, yet Elder Xi couldn't even touch Yuan's shadow after 30 minutes of trying? Just what kind of movement technique was he using?

"Let's head to the Immortal Caves now, shall we?" Yuan said to the grand elders a moment later, snapping them out of their daze.

"R-Right! Let's go!" Senior Wang nodded her head, and they proceeded to leave the area shortly after.

After they left, the spectators immediately began spreading news of Player Yuan's presence within the Jaded Garden that spread like wildfire.

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Chapter 533 Trial Disciple

"What? Player Yuan is currently in the Jaded Garden? How is that possible?"

"I am serious! I witnessed him spar with Elder Xi and win! He was even wearing his signature black mask!"

"But why would Player Yuan come here? Maybe he wants to join this faction?"

"That would be incredible if that was true. Imagine being in the same faction as Player Yuan! We'll become an unstoppable force!"

The disciples of Spiritual Elites were both baffled and excited by the news, and all of them wanted to meet Player Yuan for themselves, but that was much easier said than done, as he was currently being escorted by all six grand elders.

If they bother them, they would risk getting kicked out of the faction.

"Welcome to our Immortal Caves, Daoist Yuan." Senior Xi said to him as they approached this small mountain that had a couple of cave entrances around it.

Yuan took a deep breath, sucking in the fresh Qi from the place.

"You're right. This place has an incredible amount of spiritual energy." Yuan said to them.

"Let me show you inside the Immortal Caves." Senior Wang said as she approached one of the cave entrances.

Yuan followed her, and the closer they got to the cave, the stronger the spiritual energy became.

"Wow... This is an immortal cave?"

Yuan was speechless upon seeing the decoration inside that was the opposite of his expectations.

He'd expected the place to be a gloomy cave with nothing but rocks, but to his surprise, there was an entire room filled with furniture inside the immortal cave! And there was even a door!

"This is a modern-day immortal cave." Senior Wang said with a smile on her face.

"You probably expected something more boring, but cultivators in our day and age cultivate better in this kind of environment." Senior Wang said with a smile on her face.

"Look, there is even a bathroom in here."

After showing Yuan around the place, Senior Wang said, "If you join us, we can give you one of these immortal caves."

"Normally, only grand elders and the family heads are allowed to stay inside an immortal cave permanently, but we will make this an exception for you."

"I will consider it," Yuan said.

"Hmm..."

Senior Wang began pondering when she heard his voice that carried a hint of disinterest.

"How about this Daoist Yuan. You can stay here for a month— or even a week as a disciple. You will gain access to the Immortal Caves and some of our techniques as if you are an official disciple, but you have no obligations

to join us. And once your time as a trial disciple is over, you can decide whether you want to join us or not."

"A trial disciple?" Yuan raised his eyebrows. He didn't think they'd go this far just to invite him into their faction.

"What if I learn all of your techniques and decide not to join?" Yuan then asked.

"Of course, we have already considered this possibility, and we're willing to take the risks." Senior Wang said, as the grand elders have spoken about this matter way before Yuan even arrived.

Furthermore, while she didn't say it, she didn't believe that Yuan would be able to learn their techniques so quickly.

While Yuan's cultivation speed is, without a doubt, heaven-defying, that didn't mean he was also as talented when it comes to comprehension.

Most of their disciples needed many months to learn a single technique, and even their top geniuses required at least a week to learn a new technique.

"What do you think?" Yuan turned to ask Meixiu.

"I don't really care. Do as you wish," she calmly responded.

Yuan pondered for a moment before nodding his head, "Alright, we'll stay here for a week. After all, it would be a shame if I left so quickly after traveling so much."

"Great! Then starting today, you will be part of our Spiritual Elites! We'll get your uniforms later, but if you don't want them, just let me know."

"It's okay, we have our own clothes," Yuan said.

Although he agreed to join their faction temporarily, he didn't want to accept their uniform since that would make him look too much like an official disciple and could even potentially create some misunderstandings.

Sometime later, they left the immortal caves and Senior Wang spoke with the other grand elders regarding Yuan's decision to join the faction as a trial disciple.

Of course, the grand elders were very ecstatic to hear this.

Even if Yuan was only a trial disciple and he decides to leave in a week, they will still have a connection with him at the very least.

"Daoist Yuan, which immortal cave would you like to use for your time here?" Elder Xi asked him.

"I don't really care. Whichever one is available, I guess."

"The immortal cave I just showed you isn't occupied by anyone at the moment. You can use that one if you like." Senior Wang said.

"Okay." Yuan nodded.

Senior Wang then retrieved a jade medallion from her clothes before offering it to Yuan.

"Take this. If you run into any trouble within the Jade Garden, you can use this medallion. Only those approved by the grand elders are allowed to carry this, and anyone that dares to challenge the medallion means they're challenging us, the grand elders."

Yuan accepted the medallion without any hesitation.

"Then we will leave you alone now. If you need anything from us, you can find us at our family living quarters. Only family members are allowed to approach these living quarters, but you will be fine as long as you have the medallion on you." Senior Wang said.

"Once again, you may be a trial disciple, but you will have access to things that even normal disciples cannot reach. I hope you will enjoy your stay here."

"Thank you." Yuan nodded.

The grand elders left the scene shortly after, leaving Yuan and Meixiu alone.

"Why did you agree to stay here?" Meixiu suddenly asked him.

"During my spar with Elder Xi I realized that I don't have any combat experience in this body, so I want to acquire some of that experience in this place. After all, I cannot dodge forever, and there are a lot of interesting things that I want to try out in this place," he said.

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Chapter 534 Training

"Experience, huh? I agree." Meixiu nodded.

"Hm? Are you also interested in something from this place?" Yuan asked her.

"Yes, I want to try out archery," she responded.

"Archery? That's unexpected."

"I know, but I think it will be useful one day," she said.

And she continued, "What about you? It has to be the sword, right?"

"Yes, but that's not all I want to do. I also want to try out the other weapons, such as the spear and the rod. After all, the more I understand these weapons, the easier it will be for me when I have to fight opponents using these weapons."

"That makes sense." Meixiu nodded.

Sometime later, they entered the immortal cave and unpacked their luggage.

Once that was all done, they made their way back to the training area.

"L-Look at that person wearing the black mask! Isn't that Player Yuan?!"

The disciples around them quickly took notice of their presence due to their unique appearance.

"Is that really Player Yuan? What if he's an imposter? There are plenty of people like him out there. In fact, anyone can claim to be Player Yuan by

wearing a mask!"

Although some people stared at Yuan in awe, there were also those that doubted his identity.

After all, Player Yuan was an incredibly mysterious individual whose identity isn't known by seemingly anyone.

Furthermore, there have been far too many people faking to be Player Yuan — too many to count, and most of them do it to gain fame, or simply to obtain gifts from others, as everyone was seemingly trying to curry favors with Player Yuan, hoping to learn his identity.

Of course, due to how common fake Player Yuans were, it was only logical for people to suspect the current 'Player Yuan'.

"But didn't he fight against Elder Xi and win? Who could possibly defeat a grand elder besides Player Yuan?" Another disciple asked.

"Hmph! As if you can call that spar a fight! Elder Xi wasn't even using his full strength, and that person had been dodging the entire time! You cannot call that a fight! It was more of a performance than anything!"

Sometime later, Yuan and Meixiu arrived at the training building.

Yuan went straight into one of the sword training rooms and asked the instructor there, "Can I borrow a sword? I'd like to train with it."

"You want to practice with the sword?" The instructor was baffled by his request.

After snapping out of his daze, the instructor pointed to the side of the room where a couple of weapon shelves holding swords were located and said, "Go ahead. Most of them are wooden swords with metal as its interior so it feels like a real sword. If you want a real sword... You'll need permission from the grand elders."

"I understand." Yuan nodded and proceeded to walk over to the shelves before picking a sword randomly.

"Wow, this thing does feel pretty heavy. I am not used to feeling this much weight," he said after picking it up and swinging it around a couple of times.

"But you wield an even larger sword in Cultivation Online," Meixiu said with her eyebrows raised.

"The sword may be big, and it may seem heavy, but it actually weighs almost to nothing for me since I am its master," he said.

After picking up the sword and getting comfortable with it, Yuan said to Meixiu, "Can you bring me to a spacious area that doesn't have many people?"

Since he couldn't see the entire gymnasium even with his divine sense, he asked for her help.

Meixiu looked around the place before saying, "Follow me."

Yuan then followed her.

The gymnasium was incredibly big— big enough for them to walk a couple of minutes without stopping.

Once they stopped, Yuan used his divine sense to make sure there wasn't anyone around them.

"Stand back a little. I don't want to hurt you by accident." Yuan said to Meixiu.

Meixiu nodded and took a couple of steps back until she was many meters away from him.

Once he was alone, Yuan took a deep breath and recalled his experience in Cultivation Online.

Although his body wasn't the same, his memories and experience within Cultivation Online were real.

After standing there for a few minutes without doing anything, Yuan began moving his body, calmly swinging his sword around.

Each of his swings was incredibly precise and powerful.

The other disciples in the gymnasium could see a small arc of wind appearing in front of Yuan every time he swung the sword, causing them to suck in a breath of cold air, as none of them could replicate such a phenomenon.

"Impressive..." The instructor also watched Yuan practice his sword swings with awe.

Although there were no sword techniques behind Yuan's sword swings, his sword still emitted a profound aura, and every swing left a deep impression on the disciples there.

Yuan proceeded to practice with his sword for the next hour without any disruptions.

Sometime later, Yuan stopped swinging the sword and turned to look at Meixiu, who looked a little bored, "Meixiu, you can go practice archery if you're bored of watching me."

"Are you sure?" Meixiu asked him.

"Yes, I will probably be here for a while working up a sweat. I will find you when I am done if you're not finished by then," he confirmed.

"Okay. I will see you later." Meixiu nodded and made her way to the fourth floor, where the disciples were practicing archery."

Once she entered the room, Meixiu looked around until she found someone who looked like the instructor and walked up to her.

"Hello, I'd like to try archery," Meixiu said to her.

"Hm?" The middle-aged woman turned to look at Meixiu, who was wearing a black mask.

"Are you with...?"

Meixiu nodded, "Yes, I am."

"Have you used a bow before?" The bow instructor then asked.

"No, I have not."

"That's perfectly fine. Follow me to an open aisle. I will teach you the basics." The instructor said with a friendly smile on her face.

"Thank you." Meixiu then followed her.

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Chapter 535 Archery

"Here, watch my hands. This is how you properly hold a bow." The instructor showed Meixiu how to hold a bow.

Meixiu then followed her hand motions and gripped onto the bow.

"Good, now you bring it up like this and hold it here."

Meixiu followed her again.

"Good. Now grab an arrow with your other hand and hold it like this. Then you put it in this position on the bow..."

A few minutes later, the instructor said, "Good. Now that you know the basics, you need to familiarize yourself with them. Spend a few more minutes repeating the motion of lifting your bow and putting the arrow into the bow. Once you're ready to head into the next step, we can learn how to draw the bow and then shoot the bow."

Meixiu proceeded to spend about fifteen minutes repeating what she had learned thus far.

Once she was comfortable with holding the bow, the instructor taught her how to pull the strings back and her body position while doing so.

"Now all you have to do is release the string, but make sure you don't make any random movements. Simply release your fingers and let the bow do the rest of the work."

Meixiu followed her instructions and released the arrow, sending it flying towards the target that was 50 meters away from them.

Whoosh!

The arrow flew straight over the target and went straight into the wall that was reinforced with special material to catch arrows without damaging them.

"Nice try, but your movements were great. Now you just need to aim and hit the target. Give it a couple more tries."

Meixiu continued to shoot the bow afterward, and by her third try, she was able to hit the target in the outer areas.

On her fourth and fifth shots, she got closer and closer to the red circle in the middle of the target.

On her sixth shot, her arrow barely missed the red.

Finally, only her seventh shot, Meixiu managed to hit the red circle dead in its center.

"Not bad." The instructor said, thinking that it was merely luck.

However, Meixiu continued to shoot, and on her eighth, ninth, and tenth shot, she struck nothing but red, dumbfounding the instructor.

"Are you sure this is your first time using the bow? You're very precise..." The instructor eventually said, doubting that this was her first time using the bow.

Meixiu then said, "Yes, this is definitely my first time. Though this isn't my first time shooting at targets with a weapon since I have experience with guns."

"G-Guns...?" The instructor was left speechless by her words.

She knew that Meixiu was a young lady by her voice, but what kind of young lady would have experience shooting guns?

However, if she thought about it a little more, Meixiu was Player Yuan's caretaker. It must require extreme skill and talents to take care of someone like Player Yuan, so it sort of made sense.

Meixiu proceeded to shoot a couple more arrows at the target, and after a dozen shots, she'd managed to hit 11 of them in the red with one barely missing it.

It was clear to the instructor that Meixiu was very talented when it came to using the bow.

Meixiu also felt that using the bow was much easier than she'd anticipated. However, she felt that hitting a still target was too boring.

"Excuse me, do you have any moving targets that I can practice on?" Meixiu suddenly asked the instructor.

"Yes, we do. Follow me."

The instructor then led Meixiu into another room that was on the same floor.

Inside this room that looked a little similar to a firing range, there were a couple of puppets made of straw moving in a set path at the end of the room.

"How's this?" The instructor asked her.

"This is perfect."

Meixiu then looked for an available aisle before practicing on the moving targets.

She missed her first shot, but she immediately fixed it on her second shot, and on her third shot, she'd managed to hit the human-shaped puppet in the head.

"Who's that masked figure?" The instructor inside this room asked the instructor that came with Meixiu.

"That's Player Yuan's caretaker. I'm sure you've heard of them by now."

"Player Yuan's caretaker? No wonder why she's in that getup. But heavens, she's very good at the bow."

"You probably won't believe me when I say this, but today is her first time using the bow, and she started only an hour ago."

"What?! How is that possible?!"

The instructor smiled and said, "I asked her the same thing, and she told me that she was used to hitting targets with guns and that archery was similar."

"And you believe her?"

"There's no reason why she'd lie about such a thing. And the way she handled the bow at first convinced me that she's definitely new to the bow."

"So not only Player Yuan is an amazing individual, but even his caretakers are geniuses? Just what kind of household does he come from?"

"Who knows."

A few minutes later, the instructors approached Meixiu and said to her, "If you're already accustomed to the moving targets, you can try adjusting it using these buttons. You can not only increase the speed they're moving but also the distance."

"Once you're bored of this place, I can show you the outdoor training area."

"There's an outdoor training area?" Meixiu was interested in this place.

"Yes. You'll have more room to move around there, so you can practice moving and shooting at the same time," said the instructor.

"Just let this instructor know when you want to go. I will return to the other room for now."

"Okay."

The first instructor returned to her room training room shortly after, leaving Meixiu and her new instructor behind.

Meixiu continued practicing her archery skills that were improving at a tremendous rate, and she would remain in that room for another hour and a half before making her way to the outdoor training area with the instructor.

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Chapter 536 Avoiding and Attacking Simultaneously

"This is the outdoor training area." The instructor said to Meixiu.

Meixiu looked around, and she could see disciples practicing things other than archery there, but they were very far in the distance so they don't disturb each other.

She then looked at the disciples practicing archery, and they were running around doing complicated maneuvers while shooting their bow at the same time.

"If you thought archery was as simple as standing still and shooting your targets, you are gravely mistaken." The instructor suddenly said, and she continued, "As an archer, you must not only be precise but also nimble so that you don't get caught in the enemies' attacks."

"Watch this."

The instructor then called out to one of the disciples practicing and said, "Disciple Jing! We're going to do a quick practice!"

"Yes, instructor!"

The instructor then approached the disciple and stood a few meters away from her, who still had a bow in her hands.

"Whenever you're ready." The instructor said to her.

The disciple then took on an offensive pose and stared at the instructor with an intensive gaze.

The next second, the instructor leaped forward and attacked the disciple, but the disciple quickly reacted.

The instructor continued to attack the disciple relentlessly, but the disciple kept on dodging the attacks, and she would even sometimes use her bow to shoot an arrow at the target in the distance!

The disciple was dodging and attacking at the same time!

Their display left a deep impression on Meixiu, who was immediately in awe.

A few minutes later, the instructor stopped attacking the disciple and said to her, "Good job."

"Thank you, instructor." The disciple bowed to her.

The instructor then returned to Meixiu's side and said to her, "Did you see that? That's what archery looks like once you're proficient enough."

"Those who say archers are useless once their opponents close in on them are all worth less than shit. As that disciple had just demonstrated, one can defend themselves and attack simultaneously if they're skilled enough."

"However, to do that kind of thing requires intensive training and good movement. Your body must react instantaneously, and your body must keep up with your body's reaction, or you will only stumble and fall."

"If you intend on learning archery seriously, come here every day and I will drill everything I know into you. I don't care if you're Player Yuan's caretaker. Even if you're Player Yuan himself, I will not go easy on you." The instructor said to her.

Meixiu nodded.

Although the instructor couldn't see it due to the mask, there was a serious and passionate expression on her face.

Fortunately for her, she'd already learned a movement technique inside Cultivation Online. If she could learn this technique in the real world just like Yuan did with his movement technique, perhaps she could integrate it with her archery skills.

Meanwhile, inside the building on the first floor, Yuan was covered in sweat from head to toe as he swung the wooden sword in his arms thousands of times without stopping.

A couple of hours have passed since Meixiu left him, but he was too focused to realize this.

Suddenly, Yuan stopped swinging his sword when he felt a presence approach him.

He quickly used divine sense to see if it was Meixiu who had returned, but he quickly realized that it was someone else— someone he didn't recognize, yet he had this feeling that he has met this individual before.

It was a handsome young man with a somewhat heroic aura around him.

"Hello, Player Yuan. I apologize if I'd interrupted your training, but I cannot resist my urges, so I came here to see if you wanted to have a friendly exchange. Ah, where are my manners? My surname is Wang— Wang Ming."

The handsome young man who looked to be around the same age as Yuan introduced himself.

"Don't call me Player Yuan. It feels weird, especially since we are not in Cultivation Online." Yuan said to him, and he continued, "You can just call me Yuan."

"I understand, Yuan. Then what about my proposal?" Wang Ming asked again.

"You want a fight?" Yuan said in a calm voice.

"No, not a fight. Just a friendly exchange between two sword users. I have been watching you for a while now, silently admire your sharp sword strikes, and I began wondering what it'll feel like to be in front of it—receiving such a powerful strike." Wang Ming explained his motives.

"..."

After a moment of silence, Yuan said, "Sure. Let's do it."

Now that he was used to feeling the sword in his grasp again, he wanted to do something more intensive, and this exchange will satisfy such desires perfectly.

"We can find an empty area and do our exchange there. Since this is just a friendly exchange, we don't need to use the arena. Of course, if you want to do that, we can go there." Wang Ming said to him.

"It's fine, we can do it here."

Wang Ming nodded, and then he asked, "Do you need some time to rest? After all, you have been practicing quite intensively for a long time now."

"I'm perfectly fine," Yuan said, taking Wang Ming by surprise.

How can someone feel 'perfectly fine' after swinging such a heavy sword for many hours with barely any rest? Aren't his arms sore? Or was his body made of metal, so he cannot experience such feelings?

A few moments later, Yuan and Wang Ming found an empty spot in the gymnasium and decided to use that spot for their spar.

The disciples inside the gymnasium quickly noticed what they were doing and their blood immediately pumped with excitement.

"Everybody, look over there! Wang Ming, our number one sword genius, is going to fight Player Yuan!"

"What?!"

The disciples quickly gathered and surrounded Yuan and Wang Ming, but they made sure to not get so close that it would disturb their fight. Not only did they not want to disturb such an exciting fight but they also didn't want to get hit by either Yuan or Wang Ming.

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Chapter 537 Sword of Dominance

"Whenever you're ready, Yuan." Wang Ming said as he held his wooden sword in front of him.

Yuan also held his sword in front of him and tightly grasped the handle and nodded, "I am ready."

"Then here I come!"

Wang Ming immediately kicked his feet and lunged at Yuan before swinging his sword.

Clang!

Yuan blocked the strike with ease.

Wang Ming didn't think too much of it and continued to attack Yuan relentlessly, displaying precise and powerful sword techniques.

While he blocked every attack, Yuan examined Wang Ming's cultivation base, and to his surprise, Wang Ming emitted an aura belonging to the 7th level Spirit Warrior!

Besides the grand elders, Wang Ming has the highest cultivation base out of everyone he has met before.

Of course, this was only possible since Wang Ming belonged to the Wang Family that has known about cultivation way before the rest of the world, allowing him to start cultivating at a very young age.

However, even then, he was only at the 7th level Spirit Warrior, still 3 entire levels below Yuan.

Clang! Clang! Clang!

As the fight got longer, it also grew more intensive.

The spectators could hardly blink, as they feared that they might miss the decisive moment the second they decide to blink.

Furthermore, every time their swords clashed, it would make the spectators' hearts throb with excitement, almost like there was a drum playing.

'I can't break through his defenses! And his strikes are incredibly heavy!' Wang Ming was at a loss for words.

Although he'd expected Yuan to be a challenge for him, he didn't think it would feel so powerless, almost like he was before an immovable mountain.

'Since it has come to this, let's see if you can handle my sword technique!'

Wang Ming suddenly stopped his attacks for a moment to cover his wooden sword in his spiritual energy.

Yuan immediately noticed the change in Wang Ming's sword, but he didn't panic.

'Let's see how powerful his sword technique is!' Yuan eagerly anticipated Wang Ming's sword technique, silently wondering to himself if he would be able to defend against it.

"Yuan, if you can defend against this sword technique, it's your win!" Wang Ming announced to him.

This surprised the spectators.

"Wang Ming is using his sword technique?! Isn't that too much in a friendly exchange?"

"I think he's doing it because he's left with no other choice. Meaning that he doesn't believe that he can defeat Player Yuan without this sword

technique. Just how powerful is Player Yuan to push Wang Ming to such a state?"

"Not only does Player Yuan have his mysterious movement technique that makes it impossible to hit him, but even his sword mastery appears to be very good. If you ask me, I think he belongs to a secluded cultivation family that's outside the Six Spiritual Families!"

"Do these secluded families really exist? I mean, there are always rumors about their existence, but we haven't seen any of them even to this day."

Meanwhile, after taking a moment to prepare his sword technique, Wang Ming was finally ready.

"Here it comes, Yuan!" Wang Ming warned him before releasing the sword technique.

Yuan tightened his grasp on the sword and prepared for it.

'Sword of Dominance!'

Wang Ming's eyes flickered with a golden glow for a moment before he released his sword, sending a semi-transparent golden arc of light at Yuan.

"!!!"

Yuan immediately used his sword to block the incoming arc of light, but he had a bad feeling about it.

However, he wasn't going to dodge it, and he intended on taking it head-on.

Whoosh!

The arc of light flew at Yuan at incredible speed and arrived before him almost instantly after it was released, and the moment it touched the wooden sword in Yuan's grasp, it sliced the wood easily.

If it were not for the metal core inside the wooden sword, the arc of light would've gone straight through.

However, the metal wasn't enough to defend against the arc of light and was also being cut.

"Dodge it!" Wang Ming realized that he'd gone too far with this technique and might actually harm Yuan, perhaps even kill him.

Of course, Yuan also had a feeling that this arc of light would go through his body once it cuts through the sword.

And right as before the metal core was cut in half, Yuan sensed the danger and subconsciously reacted.

Whoosh!

A profound aura emitted from Yuan's body, sending chills down everyone's spine, and the half-broken sword in Yuan's grasp suddenly gushed with a sharp aura that sliced the arc of light in half and seemingly with ease.

"W-What kind of sword technique is that?!" Wang Ming exclaimed in a shocked voice when he witnessed his arc of light destroyed.

"Huh?"

Yuan also didn't know what happened and looked at the sword, and to his complete surprise, there was a familiar yet otherworldly aura covering the sword— it was Sword Qi!

He had somehow managed to use Sword Qi!

However, the moment Yuan lost his focus, the Sword Qi also disappeared.

The instant the Sword Qi disappeared, the half-broken sword completely broke in half, leaving everyone there speechless.

After a long moment of silence, a defeated smile appeared on Wang Ming's face, and he clasped his hands before Yuan.

"Thank you for the exchange, Yuan. It was an incredible experience for me, especially since I don't usually have anybody that can fight me equally,

much less defeat me. We should spar with each other more often— without using any sword techniques, of course."

"Likewise, it was also a good experience for me." Yuan clasped his hands together while still holding the broken sword.

"Now that is out of the way... If you don't mind, can you tell me what kind of sword technique you'd just used? I have never seen anything like that before— not even in Cultivation Online." Wang Ming then asked him, his gaze filled with interest.

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Chapter 538 A Worthy Opponen

"Of course, if you don't want to tell me, that's fine as well." Wang Ming added.

After a moment of silence, Yuan said, "It's Sword Qi."

"Sword Qi? I have never heard of this technique before. Where did you learn such a powerful technique?"

"Cultivation Online," he responded calmly.

Wang Ming's eyes widened with surprise.

As far as he was aware, there hasn't been a single person that has successfully learned a technique from Cultivation Online that wasn't a cultivation technique.

"Congratulations, Yuan. You're the first person I know of that has successfully learned a martial technique from Cultivation Online." Wang Ming said after his daze.

"Anyways, it's getting late. I will be here again tomorrow if you'd like to spar again." Wang Ming then said.

Yuan nodded.

Once Wang Ming left the scene, the crowd around them also dispersed.

However, they didn't stop talking about Yuan and Wang Ming's spar for the rest of the day.

Shortly after Wang Ming left, Meixiu returned to the first floor.

"I am finished for the day. Are you ready to leave, or do you want to train more?" Meixiu asked Yuan after returning to him.

"Let's go home. I had enough training today." Yuan said.

Then he noticed the bow and arrows in Meixiu's grasp.

"Where'd you get those?"

"The instructor gave them to me so that I could practice even at home," she said.

"Looks like you had fun today," Yuan chuckled.

"Yes, archery was more entertaining than I'd anticipated. I think I will stick with it for a little longer."

Sometime later, they returned to the immortal caves.

Yuan sat down and prepared to remove his mask, but Meixiu quickly said, "Wait a moment. Don't take your mask off just yet. Let me look around the place for a little bit."

Yuan wasn't sure what she was trying to do but he nodded his head regardless.

Then he watched as Meixiu searched every nook and cranny of the place.

"What are you looking for?" He decided to ask her.

"If there is any surveillance in this place," she calmly responded.

"L-Like hidden cameras? I don't think they would do something like that..." Yuan said in a somewhat dazed voice.

"I know, but we can never be too careful."

Many minutes later, once Meixiu was satisfied with the results, she removed her mask and said, "The place looks clear."

Yuan also removed his mask afterward.

"Ah... I am tired... I don't think I have ever practiced this intensively before, not even in Cultivation Online." Yuan released a long sigh.

Sometime later, Meixiu asked, "Do you want to take a shower first?"

"Yes, I have been sweating all day."

"You can go inside first. I will follow you after I unpack our clothes."

"Okay."

Yuan then went into the bathroom that was larger than he'd anticipated, and there was even a square bathtub in the corner.

After removing his clothes and tossing them inside the laundry basket, Yuan took a seat and started rinsing his body with warm water.

"Hmm?" Yuan noticed something different about this water.

Compared to the water in his apartment, this water actually contained a hint of spiritual energy!

"The spiritual energy in this place is so potent that it even affects the water?" He mumbled to himself.

A few minutes later, Meixiu entered the bathroom and started washing his back. Once that was done, she assisted him in the front for a couple of minutes before rinsing him off.

After drying his body, Yuan left the bathroom to wear some clothes that were neatly folded on the desk.

Meanwhile, Meixiu stayed in the bathroom to clean herself next.

Once they were both clean and getting hungry, they realized something.

"There's no kitchen in this place? So we have to eat outside?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

He didn't mind eating outside, but that would require him to remove his mask.

"We can get the food there and eat it back here," Meixiu suggested.

"Let's do that." Yuan agreed.

They then wore their masks that had been washed by Meixiu and prepared to leave the immortal caves, but right as they left the place, they noticed a figure approaching their direction.

"Senior Wang?" They immediately recognized the identity of this individual.

"Good evening, Yuan. Where are you heading this late?" Senior Wang asked them.

"We are planning on going to the cafeteria for some food since there's no kitchen in the immortal cave," he said.

Senior Wang chuckled and said, "That's exactly why I am here. I forgot to tell you about that, I am sorry."

"Anyways, the cafeteria is half an hour away from the immortal caves, and it's mostly for the ordinary disciples, so we don't normally go there when we're training in the immortal caves."

"Then where do you go?" Yuan asked.

"We either have someone deliver it to us, or we go to a special cafeteria that's made specifically for people training at the immortal caves."

Senior Wang pointed to a certain path and said, "Follow this path and you should arrive at a restaurant called 'Silver Restaurant'. It's only a five-minute walk."

She then pointed to another path and said, "There's also an open area where you can do some outdoor grilling if that's your thing."

"I understand. Thank you."

"By the way, I heard you had a spar with my grandson today, and you defeated him spectacularly." Senior Wang suddenly mentioned their exchange today.

"I knew he was from your family since he had the same surname, but I didn't think he was your grandson."

"Yes, you should've seen his face when he told me about how he'd lost to you. I have never seen him so happy despite being the loser. I think he's just happy to have a worthy opponent that can challenge him since he can defeat even the elite disciples quite easily."

And she continued, "He will surely approach you for more spars in the future. If it ever gets annoying, you can tell me and I will do something about it."

Chapter 539 A Single Bed

After their short conversation, Senior Wang left the scene while Yuan and Meixiu made their way to the Silver Restaurant.

Five minutes later, they arrive before a medium-sized building that was painted metallic white, making it appear to be made out of silver.

They quickly went inside, and to their surprise, it was completely empty.

In fact, there were only two tables in the whole building— a small square table with two seats and a large round table with 8 seats.

"I don't recognize either of you. Are you new?" The old man standing behind the reception asked them.

"Yes, today is our first day at the Jaded Garden," said Yuan."

"Then you probably don't know this, but we only serve those training at the immortal caves," he said.

"We are training at the immortal caves," Yuan said, surprising the old man.

After all, how can someone who'd just joined the faction receive the privilege to train at the immortal caves— on their first day, no less.

Meixiu could tell that the old man didn't believe them based on his expression, so she said, "Yuan, show him the medallion you got from Senior Wang."

Yuan nodded and retrieved the medallion, showing it to the old man.

The old man was completely speechless now. Even if he didn't want to believe it, he had to before the presence of the medallion.

The old man then straightened his back and bowed to them, "I apologize for doubting you two. Please forgive me."

Yuan nodded and said, "We're just here for some food."

"Of course! Tell me what you'd like to eat and I'll cook something for you." The old man said.

"Do you have a menu?" Yuan then asked.

"Nope! I can cook almost anything as long as I have the ingredients. Even if I don't have all of the ingredients, I will somehow manage," said the old man in a confident voice.

"Anything?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

He wasn't sure what he wanted to eat.

"Then how about you cook us your best dish— or whatever you recommend?" Yuan said after pondering for a moment.

"Sure thing! Give me about twenty minutes since everything will be cooked fresh. In the meantime, you can do whatever. Oh, one more thing. Would you like to eat here or would you like the food to go?"

"To go."

"I understand."

The old man then went to the back of the room and proceeded to cook.

Meanwhile, Yuan and Meixiu went outside to smell the fresh air alongside the old man's cooking that grew more delicious as time went on.

About twenty minutes later, they went back inside to grab the food.

"What's your name? People call me Chef San."

"You can call me Yuan."

"Feng," Meixiu said.

"Yuan and Feng, huh? What unique names. Anyways, I hope you enjoy the food. I'll see you two tomorrow."

After getting their food, Yuan and Meixiu returned to their immortal caves, their mouth salivating the entire time as they couldn't wait to taste whatever Chef San cooked, as the fragrance just smelled too good.

Once they returned home, they immediately opened the food, and to their surprise, there was a lot of food— more than one would anticipate for two people.

"Why did he give us so much food? Does he really expect two of us to eat all of this?" Meixiu mumbled, as there were enough to feed four— even five people.

"Maybe he was feeling generous since it's our first day here," Yuan said, not thinking too much about it.

Thus, they began eating the food shortly after.

"Heavens! The flavor is indescribably delicious! I have never tasted food this amazing before outside of Cultivation Online!" Yuan exclaimed after taking his first bite.

Meixiu nodded her head in agreement.

Besides the food at the Dragon Pavilion, nothing could compare to Chef San's cooking skills.

The food was so amazing that Meixiu was wondering if she should ask the old man to teach her how to cook better.

Of course, Meixiu is a pretty amazing cook herself, but compared to Chef San who has decades of cooking experience within a cultivation family, the disparity was too vast, and it wasn't fair to compare them.

"I'm definitely going back tomorrow morning for breakfast," Yuan said after they finished eating all of the food.

"You can really eat..."

Even though she already knew about his massive appetite, it was still surprising to see him eat so much food.

Sometime later, after washing their face and brushing their teeth, they went to the bedroom to sleep.

However, there was a problem.

"There's only one bed...?"

Yuan and Meixiu stood before the only bed in the entire place.

After all, immortal caves were built with a single person in mind, since they are mostly for training, and most people cultivate alone, so there wasn't any need for a second bed.

"At least it's big enough to fit both of us," Yuan said.

"I-It's okay, I can sleep outside," Meixiu said.

Although she had slept on the same bed with him on the airplane, she had the courage to do so only because it was for a single day. Doing so for many days was too much for her at the moment.

"That's not good. I don't mind even if you sleep with me, and where are you going to sleep outside? There are no couches." Yuan said, not minding that he has to sleep with Meixiu, as they have already done it once.

"..."

Meixiu didn't know how to respond to his question since she'd said such words without thinking about it.

Yuan then got inside the bed and under the blankets before patting the space beside him.

"Come, sleep with me," he said in a calm voice.

Meixiu sighed inwardly. Although she had thought him some common sense, there are some things that cannot be taught through words alone.

Meixiu eventually gave up and entered the bed with Yuan, spending the rest of the night together in the same bed.

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Chapter 540 Guests at the Yu Family

"Good night, Meixiu," Yuan said to her as he got comfortable underneath the blankets.

"Good night," Meixiu responded in a somewhat nervous voice, trying her best to not think too much about their situation.

'Nothing will happen... Yuan... He's not someone who would do such a thing unless I initiate it...' She eventually convinced herself that nothing will happen and slowly fell asleep.

They wake up the following morning without any incidents, and they returned to the Silver Restaurant for breakfast.

"Good morning, young lads. What do you think of yesterdays' food? Was it to your liking?" Chef San asked them the moment they entered the restaurant.

"Yes, it was amazing, and thank you for giving us so much food," Yuan said to him.

Chef San laughed out loud and said, "If I didn't cook so much food, you'd starve the entire night, young man.

"Eh?" Yuan was surprised to hear this and wondered why he would say such a thing.

"I can tell just by looking at your body— that you require a lot of energy, so I purposefully made more food for you. You eat a lot, right?"

"I-I guess..." Yuan said, completely dumbfounded now.

How does one tell how much someone can eat just by looking at their body? Is Chef San using a cultivation technique?

"Thank you for the food."

Sometime later, Yuan and Meixiu left the restaurant and returned back to the immortal caves to eat their breakfast that tasted as amazing as last night's dinner.

After breakfast, they spent a few hours cultivating, as the spiritual energy in their area was too good to not cultivate.

Once their bodies were filled with energy, Yuan and Meixiu made their way to the training tower, where they would proceed to spend the rest of the day training.

"I will see you later. If you need anything, you can find me on the fourth floor. If I am not there, I am at the outdoor training area." Meixiu said to Yuan before separating from him.

"There's an outdoor training area?" Yuan asked, as this was his first time hearing about it.

"Yes, you follow this path behind the building, and it will lead you to a large outdoor training area."

"Alright, I will check it out when I have the time." Yuan nodded.

A few minutes later, Meixiu arrived at the fourth floor and was immediately welcomed by the instructor.

At the same time, Yuan was approached by Wang Ming the moment he noticed Yuan entering the gymnasium.

"Hey, Yuan! How about another round?" Wang Ming asked with a bright smile on his face.

"Sure." Yuan calmly nodded, and they went to look for a spacious area to spar again, which quickly attracted the attention of other disciples in the gymnasium.

Meanwhile, tens of thousands of miles away, back in their hometown, the Yu Family sat before two individuals with a seemingly nervous expression on their faces, which was very unnatural and rare.

In fact, they weren't this nervous even when dealing with Chairman Zhao.

One of these two individuals was sitting on the couch, and she was a graceful young lady who appeared to be around 18 years old, wearing a luxurious red dress adorned with gems.

The second guest was an old man wearing a butler suit, and he was standing behind the young lady, clearly her caretaker.

"W-What brings you to our humble Yu Family, esteemed guests?" Yu Yong asked them.

The young lady calmly sipped on the tea that had been provided by the Yu Family before quickly putting it down.

"Whoever made this tea should learn how to make tea," she said.

Yu Yong and Tang Lee's eyebrows uncontrollably twitched when they heard her words, but they didn't get angry.

Yu Yong even put on a forced smile on his face before speaking, "I apologize for the inconvenience, Lady Chu, and I will make sure whoever made this tea will be removed for their incompetence."

The young lady didn't say anything else for a good minute before she looked around and asked, "If I recall correctly, you should have a daughter and a son. Where are they?"

Although he was taken aback by such a random question, Yu Yong responded, "They are currently busy and away from the family."

"Hmmm... Is that so?" The young lady remained calm, acting like she didn't care about his answer.

"Then where did they go?"

"Our daughter Yu Rou is currently in another city after joining a faction." Yu Yong said, purposefully ignoring Yuan.

The young lady then said, "Just your daughter? What about your son, Yu Tian?"

Both Yu Yong and Tang Lee had a bad feeling about this young lady when the name Yu Tian came out of her mouth.

"H-He's also in another city being looked at by the doctors there." Yu Yong said.

Although he could've told her that Yu Tian had left the family, he was afraid that she might ask more questions, so he gave her something less questionable.

"I see... Do you mind telling me which city? I'd like to meet him— Yu Tian." The young lady suddenly said.

"You want to meet him? Why?" Yu Yong was baffled by this sudden turn of events.

Why would this young lady who has no connection to the Yu Family suddenly want to meet their son? Could she be another one of his fans in the past?

"Why not? I heard that he used to be an amazing musician," she calmly said.

"He may have been an amazing musician, but after he got sick, he had to give up on music. Furthermore, his condition... I am afraid that you will only be disappointed." Yu Yong said.

"I won't mind it even if I am disappointed. Let me see him," she insisted.

"I'm sorry, Lady Chu, but he's currently in a situation that doesn't allow visitors. If you want, we can notify you when he returns." Tang Lee said to her, silently pondering to herself what this Lady Chu's real motives were showing up at their place.

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Chapter 541 Lady Chu

"Do you know when he'll be back? I like marking things down on my calendar," Lady Chu asked them.

"Unfortunately, we do not know when he'll return. It all depends on the doctors and his condition." Tang Lee shook her head in a regretful manner.

"Unfortunate, indeed..." Lady Chu closed her eyes and proceeded to remain silent for the next few minutes.

When she finally opened her eyes again, she stood up and said to the Yu Family, "Thank you for taking your time to entertain me even though I showed up unannounced. I will return this favor in the future."

"Don't even mention it. It was an honor to be of help to the esteemed Chu Family." Yu Yong said to her with a smile on his face.

"Let's go." Lady Chu said to the old man before walking towards the exit.

Once the young lady and the old man left the scene, Yu Yong sat back on his seat and released a stressful sigh, "Why on earth did she even come here? I was nearly shocked to death when the Chu Family visited unannounced."

The Chu Family is one of the most influential families in the world with many successful companies all around the world.

However, despite their worldwide influence, nobody really knows much about the Chu Family besides what they show the public, which is why Yu Family appeared very nervous before them.

Compared to the Yu Family, the Chu Family was incomparably more powerful and influential. In fact, it wouldn't be an exaggeration to call the Chu Family one of the top ten most powerful families in the world while the Yu Family hovered around the top 50.

"I am more worried about why she insists on meeting that trash. What should we do now? If we don't let them meet, she will definitely return and ask more questions, which wouldn't be good for our hearts, much less our reputation."

"There's nothing we can do besides hope that she forgets about our conversation today. We already kicked Yu Tian out of the household, not to mention the previous incident. I am willing to bet my everything that he will not return, and I am not going to plead him to return either."

"Furthermore, even if she returns, we can simply continue to delay it until she gives up. I highly doubt the Chu Family is willing to cause trouble for our family over something so silly."

Tang Lee nodded her head in agreement, "Even if they cause us trouble, it's nothing we can't handle. It's just going to be troublesome. Anyways, I am going to cultivate to clear my mind. Unless it's an emergency, don't bother me."

Tang Lee left the scene shortly after, but Yu Yong lingered around a little longer, silently staring at the teacup that Lady Chu had drunk from, and he wondered to himself why she wanted to suddenly meet with Yuan, who hasn't appeared in public for a decade.

"Whatever. It's best to not think about this anymore." Yu Yong shook his head before walking out of the room, trying his best to forget about what happened today.

Meanwhile, after leaving the Yu Family, Lady Chu walked to her limousine with the old man.

Once they were before the car, the old man opened the door for her, closing it after she went inside.

He then walked to the front of the car and entered the driver's seat.

"Where should we go now, Young Lady?" The old man asked her.

However, Lady Chu didn't respond, as she was completely focused on staring at the Yu Family's household.

The old man didn't rush her and patiently waited for her to respond.

A few moments later, she spoke in a calm voice, "We're going to the apartment."

"Yes, Young Lady."

The old man immediately started the car and drove her away from the Yu Family.

Sometime later, they stopped before a tall apartment.

"We have arrived at the location, Young Lady." The old man said.

Lady Chu nodded and got out of the car before turning to look at the apartment that Yuan and Meixiu lived at.

Once the old man also got out of the car, they made their way inside the apartment, but they were quickly stopped by security, who didn't recognize them, and after Meixiu's incident, security has ramped up in the apartment.

"Excuse me, are you a resident here?" The security asked them.

"No, but I am here to visit a resident," said Lady Chu.

And she quickly added, "His name is Yu Tian, and he lives on the 17th floor."

'The 17th floor?'

The security raised his eyebrows.

Although he didn't know which apartment room the incident occurred in, he knew it happened on the 17th floor.

"What's your relationship with this person?" He then asked.

"He's my friend, and I promised to visit him the last time we spoke, so here I am." Lady Chu spoke with a beautiful smile on her face, causing the middle-aged man to blush.

The security didn't think much of her answer, as there was no way that such an elegantly dressed young lady would cause any trouble.

"Please sign your name and phone number on this piece of paper and you can be on your way." The security guard said to her.

"Thank you."

After writing her name and phone number down, Lady Chu and the old man took the elevator to the 17th floor before approaching the door at the end.

As they approached apartment number 17F, the young lady could feel her body shaking uncontrollably.

"Are you okay, Young Lady?" The old man asked her when he noticed this.

"Yes, I am just a little nervous... and excited," she nodded.

The old man no longer said anything and silently followed her from behind.

Once they were standing in front of 17F, Lady Chu did not immediately knock on the door and proceeded to stand there for many minutes without moving.

She then closed her eyes to calm down, reopening them after taking a few deep breaths.

'After a decade, I have finally found you, Yuan...'

Once she was ready, Lady Chu lifted her slender arm and knocked on the door, completely unaware that the residents of 17F were away.

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Chapter 542 Following the Information

Knock *Knock*

Lady Chu knocked on the door with a resolute expression on her graceful face, but her heart was beating irregularly, almost like she'd just ran a marathon.

After all, she had waited over a decade for this moment.

A few moments went by without anyone answering the door, and Lady Chu patiently waited for an entire minute before knocking on the door again.

However, nobody answered the door.

"How weird... Where could he be at this time? According to my information, he rarely leaves home." Lady Chu wondered out loud.

"Let's wait here for a bit," she then said to the old man.

"I understand." He nodded.

Minutes quickly turned into hours, yet Yuan showed no sign of returning.

"Perhaps he moved out after that incident?" The old man suddenly suggested.

"That's not possible. I checked with the intelligence agency right before we came here. They said that Yu Tian hasn't moved out." Lady Chu said with a puzzled frown on her face.

Eventually, she retrieved her cellphone and dialed a certain number.

"Hey, it's me. I want to know where Yu Tian went. He's not home, and I have waited for many hours."

A few minutes later, the person on the other side of the phone said, "Apparently, Meixiu, Yu Tian's caretaker, brought two plane tickets to Yang City. I assume they went there for some reason."

"Yang City? What is he doing there?" Lady Chu raised her eyebrows in a puzzled manner.

"Can you check the system to see when they will return?" She then asked.

"I have already checked the system for you, Young Lady, but it appears that they didn't buy a ticket home yet."

"So either they don't plan on returning or they don't know when they'll return, huh? Keep me updated, and try to find out where they went after going to the Yang City."

"Roger, Young Lady."

Lady Chu released a deep sigh after hanging up the phone, "I waited 10 years for this moment, and he's gone off to another city with another woman? How troublesome."

"Will we be heading to Yang City?" The old man suddenly asked her.

"Of course, and we're not going to stop until I find him!"

"I understand. Allow me to prepare the airplane." The old man nodded before taking out his cellphone and making a few calls.

"I have notified the Masters that we will be going to Yang City. They said to stay away from the Six Spiritual Families' territory."

"Okay."

The two of them left the apartment shortly after and returned to the car.

Once they were inside, they drove to the airport, where their private airplane was already prepared for them, and they lifted into the air shortly after boarding.

Meanwhile, in the Jaded Garden, Yuan and Meixiu returned to the immortal caves after another day of intensive training.

After a quick shower, they went to the Silver Restaurant for dinner.

At night, they would either go to sleep or cultivate.

Yuan decided to go to sleep since his cultivation base was barely improving after he entered Spirit Master.

Meixiu decided to cultivate, as that would mean she didn't need to share a bed with Yuan, and she also wanted to take advantage of the rich spiritual energy in the area.

The two of them would repeat their next few days in such a manner.

By now, Meixiu has completely familiarized herself with the bow, and she would even spar with some of the instructors.

"Okay, let's end it here today." The instructor said to Meixiu after training with her for half an hour.

"Thank you for the session today, Instructor Li." Meixiu bowed to her afterward.

"Even though I am supposed to be training you, I am also getting good training out of this. You have improved vastly after just a few days. At this rate, you'll surpass me after a few more weeks."

"Anyways, before you leave, I should let you know that there will be a small competition amongst the archery disciples tomorrow afternoon. If you want to see how you compare with the others, you should join the

competition. The prize will be a premium bow crafted by Elder Hong himself."

"Tomorrow, right? I will be there." Meixiu nodded.

After saying her goodbyes, she went back down to the first floor, where Yuan was training with Wang Ming.

The two of them have been practicing basically every day. In fact, they fought so much that the other disciples in the gymnasium would no longer stop to watch them, as it was such a common occurrence.

The sound of wood colliding with each other would resound every time Yuan or Wang Ming swings their sword, creating this somewhat rhythmic sound.

"Hm? Is it already evening?" Yuan stopped sparring with Wang Ming once he noticed Meixiu's presence, as she would always appear when it was starting to get dark outside.

After Meixiu nodded, Yuan said to Wang Ming, "Let's stop here today."

"Alright. Oh, and before you go, there will be a friendly competition between the elite disciples next week. This will be a good opportunity for you to see what it's like fighting the other disciples, as they all wield different weapons."

"A competition, huh? That sounds interesting." Yuan nodded, and he continued, "Where will it be held?"

"I can take you there. I will tell you more about it the day before."

Sometime later, Yuan and Meixiu returned to the immortal caves.

Meanwhile, somewhere in Yang City, Lady Chu picked up her phone that had been ringing.

"Did you find out where Yu Tian went?" she asked the person on the other side.

"Yes. According to our intel, they got a helicopter service that brought them to the Jaded Garden, and they haven't returned yet, so there's a good chance that they are still there."

"Jaded Garden?" Lady Chu immediately frowned when she heard this information, as she knew that was where the Six Spiritual Families were located. In fact, it was the core of their headquarters.

However, she was advised to stay away from the Six Spiritual Families, putting her in a difficult situation.

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Chapter 543 Archery Competition

After pondering for a moment, Lady Chu retrieved her phone and dialed a number.

"Good evening, esteemed father. I am currently in a difficult situation and I need your help," she said.

Immediately, a frantic voice resounded from the phone, "What happened?! Are you in danger?! Where are you?! I will immediately send support!"

"Calm down, father. I am fine. Anyways, you told me to stay away from the Six Spiritual Families, but I might have to see them, and I was hoping you'd let me go."

"..."

Her father didn't immediately respond and took a long moment to ponder.

Sometime later, he asked her in a solemn voice, "Does this have anything to do with the person you are looking for?"

"Yes, it does. According to the intelligence agency, he is inside the Jaded Garden, and I have to go see him."

After another moment of silence, her father released a low sigh, "I promised you that if you manage to endure your training that lasted over a decade, I would let you meet this person. Although I would have preferred that you stayed away from the Six Spiritual Families since there's no other way... Go ahead. Just try to keep your identity hidden."

"I will have people on standby near that place just in case you encounter any trouble with them."

"Thank you, father! I love you! Muah!"

After kissing her father through the phone, Lady Chu hung up and turned to look at her caretaker with a smile on her face.

"We are going to Jaded Garden!" She declared.

"I understand." The old man nodded.

The following morning, they boarded a private helicopter and made their way to the Jaded Garden.

Meanwhile, Yuan and Meixiu had just finished eating breakfast.

"There's going to be a competition between the archery disciples and I am going to participate in it, so I might be a little later than usual today," Meixiu said to him as they walked to the training area.

"Really? Can I watch it? I need a break from training as well," Yuan asked her.

"I think so. I will ask the instructor."

"Okay."

After arriving at the training area, Yuan said, "Give me a minute to speak with Wang Ming since he's probably expecting to train with me today."

He then went inside the gymnasium on the first floor, and as he'd expected, Wang Ming approached him with a sword in his grasp.

"Ya ready?" Wang Ming asked him in a casual manner, feeling completely familiar with Yuan after sparring with him for the past few days.

"Sorry, but I am going to take a break today to watch Me— Feng participate in an archery tournament," Yuan said to him.

"Oh, right, there was something like that going on today. Alright. I guess I will take a break as well. To tell you the truth, my body has been aching for

a while now ever since we started sparring, but this means I am getting good training, so I don't mind it."

"And since I have nothing else to do, allow me to follow you."

Thus, Wang Ming tagged alongside Yuan to watch Meixiu's competition.

A few minutes later, they arrive on the fourth floor, where the instructor was already waiting for them.

'That's Player Yuan, huh... He certainly gives off an unfathomable aura...'

The archery instructor who was a mid-level Spirit Warrior stared at Yuan for a moment before turning to look at Meixiu, "The competition won't begin until the afternoon, but we can start making our way there now."

Meixiu nodded, and they followed the instructor to the outdoor training area, but they continued walking a little further down the path, where they arrive before a massive grassland with many people already setting up the targets for the competition.

The moment they arrived, the disciples there turned to look at them.

"Hey, look. Is that her? That 'genius' who can spar with an instructor after a few days?" One of the disciples there whispered to another.

"I think so. My instructor had been talking about her with another instructor and I happened to overhear them."

"Is she really that good? Has anybody here seen her archery skills?"

"Nope."

"Me neither."

After a disciple reaches a certain skill level, they would rarely visit the training building since they would receive new and more professional instructors that will teach them privately, hence why nobody there recognized Meixiu.

"Since we have some time, allow me to explain the competition to you."
The instructor said to Meixiu.

"There will be four different exercises, each testing your archery skills. For the first exercise, you simply need to shoot a still target to earn points, and the further target you hit, the more points you will receive."

"For the second exercise, you will have to shoot a moving target, but it won't be any ordinary targets. They change things up every year so I can't go too deep into this one. You will understand what I mean during the competition."

"For the third exercise, you will be standing on a moving platform while trying to shoot your target."

"And for the last exercise, you will have to hunt some live targets using only your bow and arrow, but there's a catch— you cannot kill these targets, or that will result in a loss of points."

Meixiu raised her eyebrows. How is she supposed to hunt something without killing it? It didn't make any sense to her.

"You probably have a few questions, but you don't need to worry, since they will all be answered later when they give more details about the competition. Until then, sit back, relax, and clear your mind."

The instructor left them alone afterward to prepare for the competition.

"What do you think? You confident in winning?" Yuan asked her.

"I can't really say for sure since I don't know how good the others are, but I will definitely try my best to win this competition," she said.

Chapter 544 The First Even

By the time the preparations were complete, all of the participants entering the competition have arrived at the place, and one of the instructors there gathered all of the participants there.

"The competition will start earlier than scheduled since everyone is here and the preparations are already complete. Take 10 minutes to prepare yourselves."

After speaking with the contestants, the instructor went to lead the spectators to the bleachers nearby.

"Good luck," Yuan said to Meixiu before going to the bleachers with Wang Ming and the others.

Once the spectators were seated, one of the instructors there began talking about the competition.

"For this competition, you will need to earn points from 4 different events, and at the end of the competition, the one with the highest score wins. As for the reward, Elder Hong from the Hong Family will personally craft you a bow."

As the instructor started explaining, six figures wearing exquisite robes could be seen approaching the area, instantly attracting the peoples' attention.

"Look over there! It's the grand elders! And they're all here!"

"Wow, it's rare to see them all together besides grand celebrations or during important events. I don't think they were even here during the last competition."

"It must be because of that person..."

The people there turned to look at the only individual that was wearing a mask sitting in the bleachers.

And just as the spectators had expected, after the grand elders spoke with the instructors, they began approaching them at the bleachers.

"Greetings, Grand Elders!"

Everybody there but Yuan suddenly stood up and bowed to the grand elders in a respectful voice.

"Don't mind us." Senior Wang said to them.

"We're just here to spectate the competition just like the rest of you."

The grand elders then turned to look at Yuan and clasped their hands towards him.

"It's been a while, Daoist Yuan. How has the Jaded Garden been treating you the past few days?" Senior Xi said to him.

"It's been great. I have gained a lot of experience here, yet there is still so much for me to do, so I'm thinking about extending my stay here if you don't mind."

The grand elders were ecstatic to hear that Yuan was planning on staying longer than a week. At this rate, he might even decide to join them!

"That's great to hear! If you need anything, just let any of us know!" Senior Wang said to him before they went to take a seat in the bleachers.

Of course, they sat around Yuan and Wang Ming.

Meanwhile, the instructors began explaining the first part of the event.

"For the first event, you will be shooting still targets. There will be three difficulties. 150 meters, 300 meters, and lastly, 500 meters. You can choose

to shoot whichever distance you want, but if you're looking for the most points, you'll obviously need to hit the furthest target."

"You get 1 point if you hit the 150-meter target, 2 points for the 300-meter, and 4 points for the 500-meter target. Furthermore, if you hit the red on the target, you will get double the points."

"You each will get 5 minutes to practice your shots before you officially begin, and once you start, you will get 3 shots with 1 minute between each shot."

'500 meters... That's really far...' Meixiu thought to herself as she stared at the small target in the distance.

The longest shot she has taken thus far was only about 200 meters, so this competition will definitely test her skills.

Fortunately for her, she had 5 minutes to practice, and she wasn't unfamiliar with shooting targets at 500 meters since she used to do it with guns.

After the explanation, the instructors told the participants to stand in their lane.

A few minutes later, all 20 participants stood in their lane with an identical bow in their grasp alongside a quiver that was filled with arrows, both provided to them, as personal items weren't allowed.

Once everyone was prepared, the instructor shouted, "Your 5 minutes of practice starts now!"

The timer started the moment a whistle was blown.

The participants immediately began practicing their shots and getting familiarized with the bow.

Whoosh! Whoosh! Whoosh!

Arrows rained down from the sky as all 20 participants shot their targets.

The majority of the participants went for the 150-meter target at first with a few going for the 300-meter target. As for the 500-meter target, nobody went for it just yet.

After spending a minute on the 150-meter target, Meixiu was already used to her new bow, and she immediately began shooting at the 300-meter target.

Her first shot landed on the target, but it didn't hit the red, so Meixiu tried again.

Three shots later, she managed to hit the red.

After shooting another 3 shots, all landing in the red, Meixiu tried to go for the 500-meter target, but she would miss a dozen of them before finally hitting the target.

Five minutes passed in the blink of an eye, and the instructor blew on the whistle again, signaling them to stop.

The spectator looked at the results. Even though it was only a practice round, they could see who had the best results.

Although everyone had managed to hit the 500-meter target, not everybody had been able to hit the red, and Meixiu was one of the few participants that didn't manage to hit the red in the 500-meter target.

However, she wasn't discouraged. Even if she loses the first event, it was not the end for her, as there were 3 more events after this one.

Once the practice ended, a couple of people went to clean the arrows off the field and replace the targets.

When that was done, the instructor gave the participants a moment to prepare themselves before she blew the whistle, officially starting the competition.

Meixiu took a deep breath, focusing on the 500-meter target. Even if she doesn't hit the red, she was confident in hitting the target, and a single 500-

meter target was worth as much as a 300-meter target in the red, so it made sense to go for the 500-meter target.

Once she was ready, Meixiu released her fingers, sending the arrow in the bow flying forward.

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Chapter 545 The Second Even

Whoosh! Whoosh! Whoosh!

Over a dozen arrows were released almost simultaneously, creating a spectacle scene.

A second later, these arrows attached themselves to the 500-meter target without a single one of them missing, and half of these arrows managed to hit the red.

However, these participants didn't have any time to look at the results and immediately began preparing for the second shot.

Three minutes passed in a flash, and the instructor blew the whistle, signaling the end of the first event.

The instructors then went to look at the targets and tallied the points.

A few minutes later, the results were in.

"Look! As expected, Jenny got first place with three perfect shots at the 500-meter target!"

"There are 6 people at second place, huh. Not bad."

"What's Me— Feng's position in the ranking?" Yuan asked Wang Ming, as he wasn't able to see the scoreboard with his divine sense.

"Feng? Let me see... She's ranked 15 out of 20. She got three hits on the 500-meter, but none of them had hit the red." Wang Ming answered his question despite thinking that it was a weird question.

After all, can't he see the scores himself?

A few minutes later, the instructor gathered the participants in another location where the second event would take place, and there was a lot of tall grass in that place.

"For the second event, you will be shooting moving targets at around 100 meters. Do you see this tall field of grass? There are machines hidden inside that will be throwing apples into the air every single, and you will receive 1 point for every apple you hit in a time limit of 1 minute."

"These machines will also throw small red marbles into the air, and if you hit these targets, you will receive 3 points instead."

"There will be no practice for this event."

Once the instructor explained the rules of the event, she called one of the participants onto the stage and gave her a minute to mentally prepare herself.

The whistle was blown a minute later, and the participant immediately raised her bow, shooting arrows at the apples that were being tossed into the air by the machines hidden within the grass.

It was unknown how many machines were hidden in the grass, but the apples would always be tossed at a different location.

And there would be a small marble the size of a pebble being thrown into the air after every few apples.

Although they were hard to hit, it wasn't impossible, and the participant managed to hit one of them during her minute-long session that exploded into tiny red fragments.

"31 points!" The instructor announced at the end of her session.

Once that participant left the stage, another one entered the stage.

"28 points!" The instructor announced a minute later.

"34 points!"

"33 points!"

"29 points!"

"51 points!"

"As expected of Xiao Mi, who is renowned for her fast shooting. Although she isn't good at long-range shooting, she's probably the best when it comes to rapid-firing with the bow, and her accuracy is very good as well."

The spectators commented as they watched the participants shoot apples and marbles.

A dozen names later, it was finally Meixiu's turn to enter the stage.

Once she was on the stage, Meixiu took a minute to calm and clear her mind.

The moment the whistle was blown, she raised her bow and started shooting arrows every second, surprising the crowd.

"Wow! Looks like Xiao Mi isn't the only one who's good at rapid-fire! Who's that participant?! I don't recognize that person! And what is with the mask?"

"You don't know? That's Player Yuan's caretaker, Feng."

"What? Really? No wonder... I guess it does require some skills to be Player Yuan's caretaker."

Although the spectators were surprised at first, once they learned that Meixiu was Yuan's caretaker, they were no longer as surprised.

Whoosh! Whoosh! Whoosh!

Meixiu kept shooting her bow almost every second until the whistle was blown.

"60 points!"

The instructor announced.

"Wow, that's even better than Xiao Mi. How many marbles did she hit? I counted 7."

"Yeah, she'd hit 7."

The second event finished half an hour later, and Meixiu had achieved first place, boosting her total rank to number 7.

"Wow, your caretaker is very talented. Where did you find someone like her?" Wang Ming asked Yuan.

"Who knows..." Yuan responded with a smile behind his mask.

Sometime later, the instructors gathered the participants again at the third location, which was a large but weirdly made platform, and it sort of resembled a treadmill.

"This is the movable platform. Watch."

The instructor pressed a button, and the stage immediately started moving one way like a treadmill.

"You will need to shoot your targets while standing on this platform. Moreover, your targets will be moving as well."

The instructor pointed to the field about 150 meters away, and there were human-figured targets moving left and right in a rhythmic manner.

"There are two targets, one at 150 meters and the other at 300 meters. You get 2 points if you hit the 150-meter target, 3 points if you hit the 300-meter, and like the first event, you will get double points if you hit the red."

"You will get 5 shots in total for this event with 1 minute for each shot, and the timer will not begin until the whistle blows."

Once again, every participant got a minute to mentally prepare themselves, and once the event began, the treadmill-like stage started moving, and it would gradually move faster after each shot.

When the treadmill stage reached a desirable speed, the instructor blew the whistle, signaling the beginning of the event.

The participant did not immediately shoot and took a moment to familiarize herself with the stage.

Half a minute later, she drew her bow and aimed it at the 300-meter target.

Whoosh!

The arrow flew straight at the target, hitting it square in the chest, but it missed the red by an inch.

Five minutes later, the instructor blew the whistle and said, "17 points!"

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Chapter 546 The Third Even

"How much more difficult do you think the third event is compared to the first or second event? Or is it easier?" One of the spectators asked out loud.

"It should probably be harder than the previous two events, especially since you have to constantly run on that treadmill stage. I cannot imagine trying to do what they're doing right now. As expected of the best archers in the Spiritual Elites."

"18 points!"

"15 points!"

"21 points!"

"18 points!"

Every five minutes a new participant would enter the treadmill stage to shoot the targets.

About an hour later, Meixiu was called onto the stage, and after spending a minute clearing her mind, she readied her bow and started moving on the stage.

Meixiu shot her bow 30 seconds after the whistle was blown while in a jogging motion.

After her first shot was released and the arrow hit the 300-meter target, Meixiu could feel the treadmill stage moving a little quicker, forcing her to jog faster as well.

Another half a minute later, she shot her second arrow.

Then her third.

And her fourth.

By the time she was on her last arrow, the treadmill stage was moving so quickly that it looked like Meixiu was sprinting for her life.

After taking a deep breath, Meixiu pulled the string with her eyes focused on the 300-meter target.

She'd managed to hit the 300-meter target all 4 times up to this point, but she has not managed to hit the red yet.

And on her last second, Meixiu released the arrow half a second before the instructor blew on the whistle.

Whoosh!

Thud!

The arrow hit the 300-meter target inside the red.

"18 points!"

After another hour, the third event came to an end, and Meixiu actually managed to increase her rank by 1 despite only hitting the red one time, reaching 6th place.

The instructor gathered all of the participants once again, but she didn't lead them to the last location just yet.

Instead, she explained to them about the event first.

"For the final event, you will be hunting rabbits within a certain area with your bow and arrow. However, you are not allowed to kill them! I repeat—you are not to kill them, or you will receive a penalty that is a deduction in points!"

"The fourth event won't start right away since we still need to prepare for it. There will be an hour break, but before I let you go on your break, allow me to explain to you the rules of this event."

"There will be a total of 10 rabbits at once, and they will all have a bell attached to their tail. Your objective for the final event is to shoot the bell off their tail, and every successful hit without injuring the rabbit will give you 5 points."

"However, if you injure the rabbit, you will have 10 points deducted, and if you somehow killed the rabbit, you will have 20 points deducted."

The participants swallowed nervously when they heard the rules, as this final event could potentially make or break their chances of becoming first place.

If they kill even a single rabbit, that would mean having an entire event's worth of points being deducted from them, meaning the points they scored in the previous events would be forfeited, and that could instantly drop even the current first place to the last place!

This rule would no doubt put a large amount of burden on the participants, and it made them really nervous for the first time in this competition.

The instructor sent the participants away for an hour while they cleaned up the place and prepare for the final event.

"You're doing great, Feng," Yuan said to her when she returned.

"Thank you, but I am still miles away compared to the others," Meixiu said.

"You're too humble." Senior Hong chuckled, and he continued, "I heard from the instructors that you only started learning archery a few days ago. Compared to the other disciples that have been practicing since they were young, you're too crazily talented, just like someone else here."

Senior Wang nodded and said, "The fact that you're even competing against them is already amazing enough."

"What? She only started archery a few days ago? How is that even possible?" Wang Ming was shocked to hear this information for the first time.

It was one thing for Player Yuan to be a genius, but even his caretaker is a genius? One can only imagine how talented his family is when the caretaker is already this talented.

While the participants waited for the final event to be prepared, outside the Jaded Garden where the helicopters are located, a new helicopter arrived at the place.

Once the helicopter landed, a beautiful young lady with brown hair flowing down her back and an old man wearing a butler suit stepped outside the helicopter.

"The spiritual energy in this place isn't that bad, but it's not as good compared to the spiritual energy at our home." Lady Chu said after checking out the spiritual energy in that place.

"Alright, now which way to do go?" Lady Chu looked around, and she quickly noticed the tall building in the distance.

"Let's go check out that place first," she said while pointing to it.

They proceeded to approach the building, entering it a few minutes later.

"Welcome to the Jaded Hotel. How may I help you today?" The receptionist greeted them the moment they entered.

"Why is there a hotel in this middle of nowhere?" Lady Chu raised her eyebrows.

The receptionist chuckled a little before replying, "Since most guests visiting this place come in helicopters, the Six Spiritual Families decided to build this hotel here for their convenience."

"I see... Then can you tell me where the Six Spiritual Families are located? This is our first time to this place."

The receptionist nodded and left the desk.

She then took them outside and pointed them in a certain direction.

"If you walk straight down that way, you should reach the entrance in about an hour since it's three miles away."

"I understand. Thank you." Lady Chu said to the receptionist before following the direction she was given.

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Chapter 547 The Final Even

An hour after the third event, the participants were gathered by the instructors, who led them to a spacious area with short grass and a massive fence that surrounded the area.

"This area is exactly 1 mile in diameter, and it is where you will be hunting the bells. There will be a total of 10 rabbits in the field, each scoring you 5 points, granted that you don't injure the rabbit."

"Moreover, each of you will have 30 minutes inside the field. However, you will only have 11 arrows in your quiver, and you are not allowed to reuse an arrow once it has been shot. Doing so will be an automatic failure."

After giving the instructions, the instructor sent in the first participant, who immediately began running towards the first rabbit she noticed.

Although 30 minutes may seem like a lot for each person, one must consider how many rabbits there were in the field. Since there are 10 rabbits in the field and the participants had 30 minutes, that gave them 3 minutes for each rabbit, not including the time they have to spend running around to find the rabbits.

The first participant noticed the first rabbit relatively easily due to the low grass and open field.

She then readied her bow and aimed it at the rabbit.

However, she didn't release the arrow and held that position for a good minute before finally releasing the arrow, as she wanted to make sure that the rabbit wouldn't suddenly move around.

Whoosh!

The arrow flew straight at the bell tied to the rabbit's tail by a single strand of string.

Ding!

The arrow struck the bell perfectly, sending it straight off the rabbit's tail.

However, the moment the bell rang, the other rabbits in the vicinity became alert and started jumping around, almost like they were trained to do so.

The participant was immediately overwhelmed by 10 rabbits jumping around, not to mention the obnoxious noises caused by the bells that would ring every time a rabbit moved, and there were 9 of them ringing at once, which easily affected the participants' focus.

Whoosh!

The participant eventually shot another arrow, but it missed the target by a large margin.

She then took a few moments to calm herself, but it was much more difficult than she'd anticipated.

Hell, even the spectators were getting irritated by the constant ringing sounds, much less the participant that was in the middle of it.

"Heavens... This last event is freaking annoying. I cannot imagine being in the field right now trying to concentrate with all the noises."

"Right? And they also have to deal with the pressure of not trying to injure the rabbit."

A minute later, someone exclaimed in a shocked voice, "Ah! She actually hit the rabbit! How unfortunate!"

Indeed, the participant had accidentally struck the rabbit with her arrow due to losing her concentration from the constant ringing.

The participant could feel her heart getting squeezed in pain when she saw the arrow struck the rabbit.

Fortunately for her, the arrow had only struck the rabbit in the leg, or she would've had 20 points deducted instead of 10 points.

Of course, 10 points was still massive, and this participant immediately dropped many ranks due to her fatal mistake.

After losing 10 points, the participant no longer had the courage to shoot her bow anymore and decided to end her session early.

In her mind, she had gained 5 points but lost 10 points, so she only lost 5 points in total. Furthermore, she was no longer in the right state of mind after that one mistake, and if she continued shooting the bow, she would, no doubt, make another mistake, which could be even more fatal than the first.

Thus, the participant decided to leave early.

"Instructor, I am done," she raised her hand and said to the instructor outside the field.

The instructor didn't say anything and merely nodded her head.

She then blew her whistle, and the rabbits suddenly stopped jumping around.

Once the participant left the field, the instructor went inside to take the injured rabbit and handed it to another disciple, who then took the rabbit to get its injury taken care of.

A few minutes later, another rabbit with a bell tied to its tail was brought into the field, and then another participant.

Meanwhile, outside the Jaded Garden, Lady Chu and her butler had just arrived at the entrance.

When the guards saw Lady Chu, they were immediately stunned by her noble appearance, as she was an immensely beautiful young lady with an

unfathomable aura that made it feel like they lived in two different worlds despite being only a few feet away from her.

"H-H-H-How may we help you?" The guard stuttered like no tomorrow when he snapped out of his daze to speak with them.

"I am here for my friend. Can you take me to him?" Lady Chu asked them with a beautiful smile on her face that immediately made them all blush even harder.

"F-Friend? Who may this friend be?"

"Well, he arrived around a week ago. I believe they came in a pair— a man and a woman." Lady Chu responded, purposefully not revealing their identity, as she wasn't sure which identity Yuan came to this place as, and saying their name could potentially ruin his secret.

"A week ago?"

"A man and woman?"

The guards began pondering, as there have been many visitors to the Jaded Garden ever since they opened up to the public.

Despite that, a couple wearing masks appeared in their minds. They figured that only 'that' person could possibly have a relationship with such an esteemed young lady.

"Are you talking about Player Yuan and his caretaker, Feng?" The guard asked just in case.

Lady Chu's expression immediately brightened after hearing Yuan's name, and she quickly nodded, "Yes! I have come here to see my friend, Yuan! Can you please take me to him?"

Chapter 548 Friend

'Player Yuan's friend?' The guards looked at each other with weird looks on their faces.

They figured Player Yuan was the type to not have any friends due to how he played Cultivation Online and how seclusive he appears, so it was quite a surprise to learn that he actually had friends.

"Umm... I'm sorry, but you're going to have to wait a while since we don't know Player Yuan's location at the moment." The guard said to them.

"We'll go ask around to see if anybody knows of his location. In the meantime, you can wait inside the guest room."

Lady Chu put on a pondering face for a moment before speaking, "I don't really like sitting around doing nothing, so can I ask to follow you to ask around? I'd like to see the renowned Jaded Garden while I am at it if you don't mind."

"O-Of course, you can follow us if you want!" The guard immediately agreed, as he couldn't resist the temptation of walking around with a beauty by his side.

"Great! Thank you in advance!"

However, there was a problem.

The guards exchanged glances once again.

The next second, they all turned to look at Lady Chu and shouted simultaneously, "Allow me to take you around!"

Indeed, the problem was who would be the one to take Lady Chu to find Player Yuan?

There were four of them, and it would make sense for only one of them to leave.

While they try to figure out that situation, at the competition, over ten participants have gone into the field and left in less than half an hour despite everyone getting 30 minutes.

The reason was simple— nobody there dared to shoot their second arrow after their first that alerted all of the rabbits.

In their mind, it was better to gain 5 points and call it a day than gain 5 points and potentially lose even more just like the first participant.

Furthermore, nobody there was really able to focus with all the noise, as it was even giving them a headache.

One might think that giving up after the first shot was unsportsmanlike, but nobody really blamed the participants for their actions— not even the grand elders.

In fact, the spectators even hoped that the participants would give up, as that meant they would have to listen to the ringing less.

"I don't understand why they would give up. Even though it's a little noisy, they should still try. After all, if they don't, they will never be able to reach first place. Even if they might lose some points, if they don't shoot, they have no chance." Yuan said out loud after seeing so many participants give up.

In his mind, weren't they all fighting for first place for the reward? What was the point of being any other place but first place since there was only one prize?

"I guess they're all just hoping for the others to shoot and lose points, allowing them to achieve first place without doing anything."

"So they're gambling that others would lose points?" Yuan was speechless, as this was his first time seeing such a thing in a competition.

As someone who has entered many competitions throughout his life, he has not once hoped that someone would mess up their performance so that he could win. It was simply an unthinkable strategy.

Meanwhile, Meixiu was called into the field.

After handing her a bow and a quiver of 11 arrows, the instructor sent Meixiu inside the still field.

And just like the other participants, Meixiu quickly took her first shot at a rabbit, shooting the bell off its tail successfully.

However, what ensued was chaos with the sound of bells resounding in every direction.

Ding! Ding! Ding!

Although it wasn't bad at first, the sound gradually got worse and more annoying.

"Do you think she's going to quit after her first shot as well?" The spectators began guessing whether Meixiu would leave early like the others or not.

And to their surprise, after her first shot, Meixiu actually pulled a second arrow from her quiver, her intentions clear!

"Oh! She's going to shoot!"

"Let's see if she hits the bell or..."

The participants watched with anticipation.

Whoosh!

Meixiu released her second arrow.

"Oh no! She struck the rabbit in the leg just like the first participant! That's a 10-point deduction!"

The participants exclaimed, and they expected her to quit after the second shot.

However, to their surprise, almost as though she didn't care about losing points, Meixiu actually retrieved the third arrow from the quiver and aimed it at the rabbit that she'd just failed to hit.

"What?! She's still going to shoot after that?!"

Whoosh!

The arrow struck the bell this time since the rabbit was injured and couldn't move properly, and for the first time in this event, Meixiu became the first to shoot a second bell successfully.

After hitting the bell, Meixiu lowered her bell and turned to look at the instructor outside.

"Take the injured rabbit out. I have plenty of time," she said in a calm voice.

The instructor nodded and quickly retrieved the injured rabbit from the field.

Once that was done, Meixiu began looking for her next target.

However, she wouldn't shoot another arrow for the next 10 minutes, and she would just silently stand there and watch the rabbits.

"She's taking her time analyzing the rabbits' movements, huh? What a smart girl." Senior Wang chuckled when she realized what Meixiu was doing.

"These rabbits were trained to move in a specific manner so if you learn their movements, you will hit them with ease."

Twenty minutes later, when Meixiu only had 10 minutes left, she began moving for the first time, raising her bow and shooting it the next second with barely any pause.

Whoosh!

The arrow struck the rabbit closest to her, hitting the bell for her 3rd bell.

After that, Meixiu would go on to rapid-fire her bow, hitting bells upon bells with seemingly no effort, shocking the spectators and the other participants.

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Chapter 549 Brother Yuan

With a little more than 5 minutes left, Meixiu left the field after hitting every single bell off the rabbits, earning her a total of 40 points, and she instantly shot up to first place in the competition.

The spectators exploded with cheering after they witnessed the spectacular display.

Meanwhile, the other participants were left speechless.

Half of them had given up after their first shot, and the other half that hasn't entered the field had planned on giving up, but after witnessing Meixiu's display, they began feeling ashamed of themselves for giving up so easily.

Therefore, the following participants to enter the field after Meixiu would go on to shoot all of the arrows in her quiver regardless if they'd hit a rabbit or not.

In the end, most of them would go on to hit at least 7 seven bells.

However, only two of them had managed to avoid injuring the rabbits.

Once all of the participants went into the field, the instructor blew the whistle, signaling the end of the competition.

At the end of the competition, the participants were gathered for the results.

"Congratulations to Disciple Xiao Mi for achieving first place! You may speak with Grand Elder Hong afterward to discuss your reward!" The instructor announced the winner of the competition.

Although Meixiu had taken first place with her performance, it was only temporary, and she ended up in the 2nd place with first place ahead by only 5 points.

If Meixiu hadn't struck a rabbit that cost her 10 points, she would've won the competition.

However, Meixiu was neither upset nor bitter since she never expected to win the competition, and she was satisfied with the experience she gained throughout the competition that she considered more of a training of sorts.

Furthermore, getting second place was already well above her expectations.

"Good job getting second place," Yuan said to Meixiu after she returned.

"Thank you."

"I was told that you only recently learned how to use the bow. Is that true?" Wang Ming asked her, as he still couldn't truly believe it.

"Yes," Meixiu confirmed, leaving him speechless.

"Regardless, that was an amazing performance. I would have never known that you were a beginner unless someone told me. Actually, you're already an expert." Senior Wang said.

"Hahaha! Miss Feng, even though you didn't win the competition, your boldness during the last event was very impressive. I even dare say that without your performance, the other participants wouldn't have dared to shoot more than one arrow," said Senior Hong.

And he continued, "Therefore, I am going to craft you a bow as well."

"Really?" Meixiu was pleasantly surprised by Senior Hong's words.

"Yes. Consider this a gift from me for entertaining us." Senior Hong laughed.

The other participants looked at Meixiu with envious gazes. If they didn't give up and had figured out the rabbits' movements earlier, they could've also gotten a bow from Senior Hong.

Meanwhile, somewhere in the Jaded Garden, Lady Chu and one of the gate guards walked around asking the people if they knew where Yuan was located, and to their surprise, the first person they encountered knew his location.

"Player Yuan? He should be at the archery competition at the moment."

"Archery competition? Is he participating?" Lady Chu asked.

"I don't know."

"Where's the competition held?" The guard asked the man.

Once they got the directions, Lady Chu and her butler began following the guard to that location.

"If you don't mind me asking, how long have you known Player Yuan?" The guard asked Lady Chu as they walked.

"I have known him ever since we were young," she said with a gentle smile on her face that caused the guard to swallow nervously when he saw it.

"So you're childhood friends, huh? How envious."

"No, we're more than just childhood friends. You can even call us a family," she said.

"Eh?"

The guard raised his eyebrows, unable to comprehend the real meaning behind her words.

Sometime later, they arrived at the location of the archery competition, and when they arrived, the competition had just ended.

The moment they arrived, Lady Chu instantly noticed the tall figure wearing a black mask within the crowd, and she proceeded to stand there and silently stare at him with a dazed look on her face.

At this moment, it seemed to her as though the world had stopped moving — that everything else but the masked man had disappeared from her sight, almost there was only him and her in this world.

"Brother Yuan..." She muttered in a low voice.

However, despite her excitement and desire to jump into his embrace, Lady Chu didn't immediately run to him.

Instead, she stood there without moving, almost as though she didn't know what to do.

After waiting for over a decade for this moment, Lady Chu figured that she would be prepared to finally see him again, but to her surprise, when it was actually time to see him, her body froze with nervousness.

'What if he doesn't remember me?'

This thought that hasn't appeared in her mind for the last decade suddenly appeared for the first time.

Indeed, she feared that Yuan had forgotten about her. After all, 10 years was a long time, and people tend to forget about their childhood.

'Maybe I should just watch over him from a distance for now...' Lady Chu suddenly had this thought.

However, before she could even decide, she noticed the person that she had been staring at suddenly turn to look in her direction.

Lady Chu's heart immediately began throbbing like crazy, and her body became so stiff that she couldn't even move a finger.

Fortunately for her, Yuan had only glanced in her direction because he felt that someone was staring at him from her direction, but his divine sense

wasn't strong enough to see Lady Chu, so he turned back around a moment later.

Lady Chu released a sigh of relief after seeing this, but then she became even more nervous a few seconds later.

'What should I do now?' she wondered inwardly.

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Chapter 550 Do You Remember Me, Brother Yuan?

'Brother Yuan... You're so close to me, yet you feel so far away...' Lady Chu continued to stare at Yuan's figure from a distance for many moments.

The guard wondered when she was going to approach Yuan, but he noticed her expression and decided to simply wait for her to do something.

The old man stared at Lady Chu with a profound gaze, as this is his first time seeing her acting this timid and nervous, looking like a lost little girl.

"Young Lady."

The old man suddenly called out to her, and he asked, "Shall we go home?"

"No!"

Lady Chu subconsciously responded.

She then took a deep breath to calm herself down, but a single breath wasn't enough, so she took a few more deep breaths.

Once she was ready, Lady Chu took her first step forward and slowly approached Yuan.

The people there quickly noticed Lady Chu's presence due to her formidable aura that caused them to subconsciously turn and look at her, almost like their senses felt something threatening coming from her direction.

When the grand elders saw Lady Chu, their eyes immediately widened with shock, but it was not because they recognized her. In fact, they didn't know her.

"S-Spirit Master!" Senior Wang muttered in a low voice that was filled with disbelief.

Indeed, Lady Chu was emitting the aura of a Spirit Master just like them, albeit a little weaker.

However, despite that, it was incredibly shocking to them since Lady Chu only looked to be around 18 years old.

"Who is that?" One of the grand elders asked as Lady Chu slowly approached them.

"No idea, but to be a Spirit Master at such a young age... I thought it was only possible for someone like Daoist Yuan..."

With everybody there suddenly turning to look in the same direction, Yuan subconsciously turned his head and did the same.

Once Lady Chu entered his divine sense's range, Yuan was finally able to see the beautiful young lady that stunned everyone there.

'Who is that? She looks so familiar for some reason...'

Yuan didn't recognize Lady Chu at first, but he felt a sense of nostalgia when he saw her sparkling hazel eyes.

However, he was still unable to recall where he'd seen her before.

Lady Chu walked until she stood a few meters away from Yuan, and she proceeded to stand there in silence.

"How may we help you?" Senior Wang asked when Lady Chu didn't say anything for a while.

Of course, Lady Chu didn't respond to her, as the only thing in her eyes and mind right now was the masked man that was only standing a couple of meters away from her.

"Brother Yuan... I have finally fulfilled our promise..." Lady Chu suddenly muttered in a low voice.

Yuan's body shivered for some reason when this unknown lady called him 'Brother Yuan', and his sense of nostalgia grew more intense.

"Do you remember me, Brother Yuan?" Lady Chu asked him in a slightly louder voice.

Yuan stared at Lady Chu intensively for many moments before shaking his head, "I am sorry, but I don't recognize you. Have we met before?"

Lady Chu closed her eyes and released a deep sigh.

She then opened her eyes that flickered with resolve, and she spoke in a calm voice, "Well, I won't blame you for not recognizing me since it has been over a decade since our last meeting, and we were only children back then."

"Over a decade ago?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

Suddenly, the image of a little girl with brown hair and hazel eyes appeared in his mind, and she somewhat resembled this beautiful young lady.

Yuan's body trembled when he suddenly had an idea of this young lady's identity, but before he could open his mouth to speak, Lady Chu retrieved a silver harmonica from her pocket and blew into it, creating a beautiful sound that was filled with harmony.

Seeing the silver harmonica in Lady Chu's grasp and hearing this song, Yuan was absolutely certain about her identity.

"Y-Y-You are... Lulu?" Yuan spoke in a dumbfounded voice.

A blissful smile appeared on Lady Chu's beautiful face, and she responded in a clear voice, "It's not Lulu. It's Liuxiang. How many times have I told you to stop calling me by that nickname now?"

Of course, Yuan remembered that her name was Liuxiang, but he was used to calling her Lulu since he wasn't able to pronounce the name 'Liuxiang' properly back then, so he gave her a much simpler name to call, and that nickname was Lulu.

"W-What are you doing here?" Yuan randomly asked her, as he wasn't able to think properly due to her sudden appearance.

"What do you think, you idiot? I came here to find you since you didn't come looking for me! Just like we had promised! Or did you forget about that?" Lady Chu said.

Memories began flashing inside Yuan's head after hearing her words.

Outside this remote building that had the sign 'Jade Orphanage' on the doors, he stood before Lady Chu when she was still a little kid.

"Don't leave me behind, Brother Yuan!"

"Don't be sad, Lulu. Although I have to leave now, we will definitely see each other again in the future. If I cannot look for you for some reason, then you should come to look for me. Here's my harmonica. You can keep it until our next meeting." Yuan handed her a silver harmonica that was too big for his small hands.

"It's a promise!"

"Un."

After hugging her, Yuan left the orphanage with a beautiful woman that was Meifeng, who had come to take him away from the orphanage after the Yu Family adopted him into their family, and that was the last they saw each other.

"I remember... I'm sorry that I couldn't find you... No, I didn't even try to..." Yuan apologized to her in a sighing voice after recalling some of his memories that he hid deep within his consciousness after entering the Yu Family.

"You don't have to apologize since I am well aware of your situation. It was simply impossible for you to do anything. Anyways, why don't we continue this conversation somewhere more private?" Lady Chu said.

"Okay." Yuan quickly nodded.

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Chapter 551 Chu Liuxiang

"Let's go, Brother Yuan." Lady Chu said as she walked to stand beside Yuan.

Yuan nodded and said, "We can go back to the immortal caves for now."

He then turned to look at the grand elders and said to them, "Please excuse us."

The grand elders didn't say anything and silently nodded their heads in a dazed manner.

"Follow me."

Yuan began walking back to the immortal caves with Lady Chu following closely beside him.

As for Meixiu, she quietly followed them from behind, silently wondering to herself what kind of relationship they had and how they knew each other.

Lady Chu's butler also followed them from behind Meixiu.

'I don't recall seeing this woman before... Just where did she meet Yuan? They also seem to go way back...' Meixiu wondered to herself.

She had been with Yuan ever since he was adopted into the Yu Family, and as Meifeng's daughter, she got to see a lot of influential people. However, she doesn't recall this hazel-eyed beauty, who definitely looked very influential just by her graceful appearance alone.

Their journey back to the immortal caves was a quiet one without anyone starting a conversation.

Yuan was still in a daze because of his sudden reunion with Lady Chu, who has been by his side even before he could learn how to walk in the orphanage.

As for Lady Chu, she was too nervous to say anything, and she was satisfied with just being by his side again.

Eventually, they reached the immortal caves, and Yuan brought them inside.

"Is he with you?" Yuan turned to look at the old man that had been following them but stopped at the door.

"Yes, he's my caretaker. You can trust him." Lady Chu nodded.

"Are you coming inside?" Yuan asked him.

"I don't want to disturb the Young Lady's reunion so I will wait out here until you're done," he said to them in a calm voice.

Once they entered the immortal caves and sat down, Yuan removed his mask and said, "Before we start our conversation, allow me to introduce you to each other."

"Meixiu, this is Liuxiang, a very important friend of mine from the orphanage that I used to live at before I was adopted into the Yu Family. And Liuxiang, this is Meixiu, my caretaker, who is also very important to me."

"Hello," Meixiu said to her in a low voice.

"Hello..." Lady Chu responded in a similarly low voice.

Although this is Meixiu's first time hearing about Lady Chu, it wasn't the same for Lady Chu, who has known about Meixiu for many years now.

After the brief introduction, they returned to being silent, as both of them had so many questions but didn't know where to start.

Eventually, Yuan said, "Well... Let's start with you, Liuxiang. What happened to you after I left the orphanage?"

"I know I told you to stop calling me 'Lulu', but it doesn't feel right when you call me anything else, so you can continue calling me 'Lulu'." Lady Chu said.

And she continued, "Anyways, shortly after you left the orphanage, I was also adopted and entered the Chu Family, so I am currently Chu Liuxiang."

"I see... I hope you lived a good life after your adoption." Yuan said to her.

Chu Liuxiang chuckled and said, "Hardly. My life has been repetitive, boring, and even painful at times ever since I joined the Chu Family."

"What do you mean?" Yuan asked.

"You can probably tell from my aura that I am a Spirit Master just like you, right? Well, the Chu Family is actually a hidden cultivation family, but unlike the Six Spiritual Families that live in seclusion and away from society, we hide in plain sight."

"The Chu Family is an immensely successful family in the modern world with many businesses around the world, but at the same time, it's also a cultivation family that has known about cultivation since ancient times."

"So you've been cultivating ever since you were young?" Yuan asked.

"Yes. Apparently, I have the perfect body for cultivation, and someone from the Chu Family noticed my talents by chance and decided to take me into their family. In other words, they adopted me for my cultivation talents, and I have been cultivating in seclusion ever since I joined the Chu Family."

"That means I cannot leave the Chu Family's territory. Although they have a lot of land, and there were a lot of things to do, it was still a boring life, especially since I spend most of my time training and cultivating alone..."

"Hell, I can even count the number of people I have met during the last 10 years using just my hands. Of course, I am still grateful to the Chu Family

for adopting me, and they treat me very well."

"That does sound like a very boring life..." Yuan agreed with her.

He can imagine how Chu Liuxiang felt since he also had to spend many years in seclusion inside his room and without the ability to move his body.

"It was painful at times, but it wasn't that bad overall, especially when compared to your life at the Yu Family..." Chu Liuxiang sighed.

"Huh?"

Seeing Yuan's puzzled face, Chu Liuxiang continued, "I know what the Yu Family made you go through, Brother Yuan. I know how they treated you like a tool for their own benefit and how they tossed you away like trash when you suddenly became sick and was no longer useful to them."

"I am sorry that I wasn't able to come to you sooner, Brother Yuan, but I wasn't allowed to do anything until I finished my training, nor was I aware of your situation until the end of my training... If I had known about it earlier... Then maybe you wouldn't have had to suffer so much... You didn't deserve any of that..." Chu Liuxiang sighed, even feeling the urge to cry.

A gentle smile appeared on Yuan's face after hearing her words, and he said, "It's okay. Although it was painful at times, there were also joyous moments that made everything worth it in the end— at least that's what I think."

Chapter 552 Harmonica

"After all, I got to meet with people like Meixiu, Yu Rou, and the others... If I hadn't joined the Yu Family, I wouldn't be in this position right now, so even if I had to suffer a little, it was all worth it in the end." Yuan said with a gentle smile on his face.

'Yuan...' Meixiu looked at him with an emotional gaze.

"By the way, how did you manage to find me? Even though I came here as 'Yuan', there are many Yuans in this world. How did you know I was the one you were looking for?" Yuan asked Chu Liuxiang a few moments later.

"I knew you would achieve great things in the future, so when I learned about Player Yuan, I was certain that you were the one I was looking for."

"Of course, I followed 'Yu Tian', not Yuan."

"My family owns an intelligence agency so I have a lot of information, and I followed your information to the Jaded Garden."

"Ah, but you don't have to worry about your identity as Player Yuan being leaked since only my parents, my caretaker, and myself know about it. Of course, they can all be trusted."

Yuan nodded. Now that he can move around properly, he wouldn't care as much even if his identity is leaked.

After all, he now has the power to protect himself and those around him.

"Brother Yuan... Here you go."

Chu Liuxiang retrieved the silver harmonica again and placed it on the table in front of them.

"Now that I have reunited with you and fulfilled our promise, this harmonica shall return to its rightful owner."

Yuan looked at the silver harmonica for a moment before picking it up.

Even though it was much lighter than he remembers, it still brought back the countless memories he had with this harmonica.

"I still remember how you and the others would ask me to play this harmonica every chance you got, and how you would bug me until I agreed," he said with a gentle smile on his face.

He then placed the harmonica on his lips and began blowing air into it.

Music notes filled the room as Yuan played the song that used to fill the orphanage with joy.

Hearing and seeing Yuan play the silver harmonica again, tears began flowing from Chu Liuxiang's eyes, as she had dreamed of this scene nearly every day for over a decade.

A few minutes later, Yuan placed the silver harmonica back on the table and said to Chu Liuxiang, "You can keep this harmonica."

"Huh? Really? Why don't you want it?" She asked him in a surprised voice.

"It's not that I don't want it, but it has been in your possession for far longer, so you are now the rightful owner. Furthermore, I believe that you value this harmonica more, so I cannot convince myself to take it away from you."

"Are you sure, Brother Yuan?" Chu Liuxiang asked, feeling a little hesitant.

"Yes, I am sure."

"If you say so..." She picked up the harmonica and held it close to her chest.

Even though she has had this harmonica for over a decade and had only let it go for a few minutes, it gave her a completely different feeling in her hands now, and it actually felt like it belonged to her.

"Lulu, what are you going to do now that you found me? Are you going to return to the Chu Family anytime soon?" Yuan asked her a moment later.

"No, I have already completed my training, so I don't really have to return until my parents summon me for whatever reason, and I planned on staying with you for a while... If you don't mind."

"I don't mind, but there really isn't anything to do in this place besides training..." Yuan said.

"Are you staying in the Jaded Garden permanently?" Chu Liuxiang then asked.

"No, we're only here temporary as trial disciples. We were supposed to leave after a week, but we decided to stay here a little longer for more training."

"I see... Well, I don't really care where we are or what we are doing as long as I am by your side," she said.

The two of them proceeded to talk about their own lives after leaving the orphanage until it was late and Yuan was getting hungry.

"Let's go get some food to eat before we continue. I know this place that cooks extremely delicious food." Yuan said to her.

"Okay."

After wearing their mask, Yuan and the other two left the immortal caves.

"Sebastian, we're going to get some food." Chu Liuxiang said to the old man who had been standing outside the immortal caves like a statue this entire time.

"I understand," he said, and he began following them to the restaurant.

"Hm? Who is this young lady? Your girlfriend?" Chef San asked in a joking tone when he saw Chu Liuxiang with Yuan.

"Hello, I am Chu Liuxiang, a longtime friend of Yuan," she introduced herself.

"I see. What would you like to eat today? Or would you prefer I cook something random like usual?" Chef San then asked.

"Do you have any preferences, Lulu? We don't really care what we eat since everything Chef San cooks is amazing." Yuan asked her.

"I'm not a picky eater. I will have whatever they are eating," she said.

"Alright. Give me some time." Chef San then went to the back to start cooking.

While they waited, Chu Liuxiang went outside to play the harmonica for Yuan and the others.

"You have gotten really good at playing the harmonica, Lulu." Yuan chuckled, and he continued, "Especially compared to back then when you would blow it randomly and call it a 'unique song'."

Chu Liuxiang smiled and said, "Besides training and cultivation, I would spend all of my spare time playing the harmonica. Of course, I am still nowhere as good as you even if I were to compare my current self to you back then."

"Here. It's your turn now," she then handed the harmonica to him in a casual manner.

Yuan accepted the harmonica and began blowing into it without cleaning it even though Chu Liuxiang had played it just moments ago.

Chu Liuxiang blushed slightly when she saw this, but she didn't say anything.

Chapter 553 - A Beauty On Each Side Of The Bed

"Thank you for the food, Chef San."

After waiting for about half an hour, they finally received their food, and they immediately made their way back to the immortal caves.

Once they were seated, they began eating the food.

"Wow, you're right. This food is amazing. I dare say it's even better than Sebastian's food, and that's a huge compliment." Chu Liuxiang's eyes widened with surprise the moment she tasted the explosive flavor.

And in just a few minutes, Chu Liuxiang consumed all of her food, becoming the first to finish.

"Brother Yuan, I just noticed this, but you sure have a lot of food... Can you really eat all of that?" She asked him when she noticed that his portions were multiple times larger than theirs.

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"Hm? Yeah, I can eat all of it." He quickly swallowed before nodding his head.

"So you have a really big appetite, huh? That's something I should note down for the future..." She mumbled in a low voice, but Yuan wasn't able to understand the meaning behind her words.

Sometime later, they finished all of the food.

Meixiu stood up and prepared to clean the table, but the old man, Sebastian, said to her, "It's okay, young miss. Allow me, the guest, to clean the table for you."

"Okay..." She nodded.

While Sebastian cleaned the place, Chu Liuxiang asked, "How many rooms do you have in this place?"

"There's only one room and one bed." Yuan calmly responded.

"Eh? So you have been sleeping together?" Chu Liuxiang looked at them with her eyes slightly widened.

"Yes," he casually responded.

Chu Liuxiang turned silent for a moment before asking, "Can I see the bed?"

"Of course. That's the bedroom." Yuan pointed to their room.

Chu Liuxiang then opened the door to take a look at the size of the bed, and sure enough, there was plenty of space— enough for three, perhaps even four people.

"Do you mind if I sleep with you two?" Chu Liuxiang then asked them in a resolute voice.

"Of course. Where else are you going to sleep?" Yuan said.

"Young Master Yuan, I will sleep out here in the living room on the couch," Sebastian said to him since he has no intention of sharing a bed with three young people, and one of them was even his master.

"As long as you're not sleeping on the floor." Yuan nodded.

Sometime later, Chu Liuxiang said, "Brother Yuan, I am going to wash myself. Where is the bathroom?"

"That door right there. Do you have any extra clothes with you?" Yuan asked her after realizing that they didn't have any luggage with them.

"Oh, right. Now that you mention it, we left them inside the helicopter." Chu Liuxiang said.

"I shall go and retrieve our luggage at this moment," Sebastian said.

"Are you sure? It's already really dark outside. This is also your first day here, so you might get lost." Yuan asked him.

"If you want, I can lend you my pajamas for today since I have an extra pair," Meixiu suddenly said.

"If you don't mind." Chu Liuxiang calmly agreed.

After Meixiu handed her own pajamas and a towel to Chu Liuxiang, she whispered something in Chu Liuxiang's ears.

"No, I don't need them. Thank you for asking." Chu Liuxiang shook her head before entering the bathroom and locking the door.

About half an hour later, Chu Liuxiang returned outside while wearing Meixiu's pajamas that felt oddly fit, almost as though they belonged to her.

'So we are equal when it comes to our body, huh?' Chu Liuxiang wondered inwardly.

After Chu Liuxiang finished, Yuan went to clean himself next.

Of course, Meixiu didn't follow him inside like she normally would, as there was no way that she'd do anything to Yuan with guests around.

Meixiu went inside the bathroom after Yuan, and Sebastian was the last to enter.

Once they were ready to sleep, Chu Liuxiang followed Yuan and Meixiu inside their bedroom while Sebastian slept on the couch.

"Where do you want to sleep?" Yuan asked Chu Liuxiang, giving her the choice to pick.

"Brother Yuan, you can sleep in the middle. I will just sleep beside you," she said.

"Okay," he nodded.

A few moments later, Yuan laid in the middle of the bed while sandwiched by two beauties, one on each side.

If any human being that wasn't Yuan saw this scene, they would definitely vomit blood from envy.

"Brother Yuan, do you remember how we would always share a bed in the orphanage?" She asked him.

"Yes, because you were always afraid that something was hiding under your bed," he chuckled.

"I-I don't recall such a thing! You must have remembered it wrong!" She quickly refuted with a slightly rosy face.

The two of them proceeded to spend many minutes reminiscing their time together in the orphanage.

Meixiu had her eyes closed the entire time, seemingly asleep, but she was actually wide awake and silently listened to their conversation, as she was learning a lot about Yuan and his relationship with Chu Liuxiang.

And the more she listened, the more obvious it was to her that they were definitely very intimate with each other.

Meixiu then recalled what her mother told her not long ago— that someone will take Yuan away from her if she's too slow, and this caused her heart to tremble.

"Sorry, Meixiu, I got too caught up in our conversation and almost forgot that we're trying to sleep." Yuan suddenly said to her.

However, Meixiu didn't say anything and pretended to be asleep.

Seeing that Meixiu didn't respond, Yuan released a sigh of relief knowing that she managed to fall asleep despite their conversation.

"Let's lower our voices so that we don't wake her up," he said to Chu Liuxiang in a low voice, who was lying on the bed on her sides so that she could stare at Yuan's face.

They then continued reminiscing about their past for pretty much the majority of the night.

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Chapter 554 - Do You Desire Revenge?

"Brother Yuan, I have been wondering... Aren't you angry at the Yu Family for what they have done to you? Don't you desire revenge? They treated you like an animal, after all. If I speak with my family, they should be able to do something about the Yu Family." Chu Liuxiang suddenly asked him after they finished reminiscing their past.

"Honestly, I have never really thought about it seriously. When you say revenge, what do you expect me to do? I do not like unnecessary violence, and even though they have done some horrible things that deserve some sort of punishment, I don't think violence is the right answer."

"I know, Brother Yuan, that you're not the violent type. However, there are other methods to cause pain to the Yu Family without actually hurting them. For example, you can ruin their company, or you can destroy their family by tearing them apart."

"How is that any different? They all sound pretty violent." Yuan sighed.

"The most obvious difference is that you won't need to physically hurt them since you will be doing it mentally... You can simply start up your own company and grow to become an even more successful business than the Yu Family. That will definitely make them regret throwing you away."

"Or, you can reveal yourself as Player Yuan, instantly gaining worldwide fame. This will make the Yu Family regret ever treating you wrongly, and they will be kicking themselves for the rest of their life knowing that they'd tossed away the one and only Player Yuan."

Yuan turned silent to ponder. Can these methods really help him take revenge against the Yu Family for mistreating him and many other things? However, it does sound better than getting violent with the Yu Family.

"Brother Yuan, if you want, I can help you. Let's make the Yu Family regret treating you the way they did!" Chu Liuxiang said to him with a resolute look in her gaze.

Yuan sighed and said, "As much as I want to make the Yu Family suffer for what they have done, I cannot bear to hurt Yu Rou, who is also part of the Yu Family, and I am afraid that hurting her family will also hurt her."

"I don't think Yu Rou will be affected, since she has already left the family. While she has the Yu Family's surname, it doesn't mean that she will follow in their footsteps. If you're really that worried, you can simply take Yu Rou into your faction."

"My faction...?" Yuan mumbled in a low voice.

"I don't have a faction."

"Then you should start one— at least I think you should start one. You have the capabilities and the resources to create one of the strongest factions in the world. If you create a faction, I will also join you, and with two Spirit Masters, I don't think we will have any competitions for a long time— long enough to reach the peak and solidify our foundations."

Yuan turned silent to ponder, as he has never really thought about starting his own faction since that was akin to starting up his own sect in the cultivation world.

Does he have what it takes to manage a faction? What if things don't work out? And what if it brings more trouble than good?

"Wouldn't it be easier if we all just joined an existing faction that already has its own foundation? Take the Spiritual Elites for example. I think they're a trustworthy bunch."

Chu Liuxiang shook her head on the pillow and said, "I don't know much about the Spiritual Elites or the Six Spiritual Families operates, and I believe you when you say that they are trustworthy, but I still think that it would be for the best if you created your own faction."

"This way, you don't have to worry about any restrictions in the future, and you can do everything at your own pace. If you join another faction, you will never fully be able to spread your wings— at least that's what I believe."

"Alright, give me some time to think about all of this since it's not something I can rush."

"Take all the time you need, Brother Yuan, since I will always be by your side now." Chu Liuxiang giggled in a low volume.

Eventually, Chu Liuxiang started getting sleepy, but before she closed her eyes, she made sure to snuggle herself closer to Yuan.

Yuan could feel her soft body clinging to him, and he could smell the soothing fragrance coming from her silky brown hair, but he didn't think too much of it and also went to sleep, as he was used to sleeping with her in such a manner back in the orphanage.

The two of them quickly fell asleep, and once Meixiu could no longer hear them talk, she also decided to finally go to sleep.

The following morning, Yuan woke up with a somewhat heavy feeling on his body, and it felt like something was restricting his body.

His heart immediately began beating nervously since his initial thought was that his body had suddenly returned to being crippled.

However, he quickly realized that was not the case, and the reason for this heavy feeling was Chu Liuxiang, who had somehow managed to climb on top of his body, and she still appeared to be asleep.

A relieved smile appeared on Yuan's face when he recalls how Chu Liuxiang has bad sleeping habits and would always toss around in bed.

'How am I supposed to get out of this without waking her up?' Yuan sighed inwardly.

Chu Liuxiang was not only lying on top of his body, but she was also hugging his body like a koala hugging a tree.

Then Yuan noticed something soft pressing against his chest, and he realized that it was caused by Chu Liuxiang's breasts.

However, they felt softer than when he accidentally touched Meifeng's breasts who was wearing her undergarments at that time.

Indeed, Chu Liuxiang wasn't wearing any undergarments as of this moment since she didn't have her luggage, and she would rather not wear anything than reusing her old ones, but it was not as though she wasn't offered some by Meixiu.

But for some reason, Chu Liuxiang refused Meixiu's offer and decided to sleep without any undergarments.

Yuan eventually got Chu Liuxiang off his body, and to his surprise, it didn't wake her up.

'Oh, right. She's also quite the heavy sleeper.' Yuan then recalled this detail.

He left the bedroom shortly after, and he noticed that Sebastian was already awake and sitting on the floor in the lotus position, seemingly cultivating.

Yuan decided to not bother him and approach the bathroom, but before he could walk two steps, Sebastian opened his eyes and turned to look at Yuan.

"Young Master Yuan, if you don't mind, can you spare me some of your time? After you come out of the bathroom, of course."

"Sure," he casually nodded, thinking that this probably had something to do with Chu Liuxiang.

After washing his face and brushing his teeth, Yuan came back outside, and Sebastian was already standing at the door.

"Let's talk outside, shall we?"

Yuan nodded and followed him outside after changing out of his pajamas and wearing his mask.

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Chapter 555 - You Are The Problem

Once they were outside, Sebastian tilted his head to look at the clear blue sky for a silent minute before turning to look at Yuan.

Sensing Yuan's nervousness, Sebastian showed a friendly smile and said, "There's no need to be so tense. I just wanted to thank you."

"Thank me? For what?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"For accepting the Young Lady despite being separated for so long. I don't know how much she told you about the Chu Family, but she lived a very reclusive and boring life there with barely any interactions."

"Besides her family, myself, and a few other instructors, the Young Lady doesn't have any friends, so she was always bored, and she would always complain to me."

"Of course, there isn't anything I could do for her except listen to her complaints."

"This is my first time seeing the Young Lady so excited and blissful, and I am thanking you for that..."

"You don't have to thank me for that. I have known Lulu ever since the orphanage, and we were the closest thing to a family back then. No matter how much time has passed, I will always value her as such." Yuan said to him.

Sebastian nodded, and then he asked, "Do you have any plans for the future?"

"That's a very vague question..."

"I kept it vague on purpose since I don't know anything about you besides the fact that you're Player Yuan and that you're the Young Lady's childhood friend. What do you see yourself doing in the future?"

"Are you going to continue living like this, doing whatever you please, or do you intend on doing something big like standing at the top of the world? Maybe you will even start a family and settle down somewhere in the world."

"I can't tell you anything since I don't know what I want to do myself. I have only recently regained my ability to move, so not long ago, I didn't even have the luxury of deciding what I want to do, since there's literally nothing I can do in that state."

"Fair enough." Sebastian nodded.

"Then allow me to ask you this... Where do you see yourself with the Young Lady in the future?"

"With Lulu? I hope we can continue being close to each other, I guess, but that will also depend on what she wants to do with her life."

Sebastian remained silent for a moment before speaking, "You see, the Young Lady is a very important individual within the Chu Family, and being one of the most powerful families in the world, the Young Lady will definitely become a grand figure in the world."

"The Masters— her parents haven't decided on what they want to do with her after she finished her training, hence why they allowed her to do as she pleases for now. However, once they have come to a conclusion, they will ask her to return to the family."

"Maybe they will make her take over the family, or maybe they will send her to another family through marriage. We won't know until that day comes. However, regardless of what her parents want the Young Lady to do, there will be a problem."

"And that problem is you, Young Master Yuan."

"Huh? Why would I be a problem?" Yuan asked, as he was truly puzzled.

"You're too important to the Young Lady. I dare even say that you're more important to the Young Lady than the Chu Family is to her, so if she has to pick between you or the family, she will most definitely pick you— that is what I believe after seeing you two together for less than a day."

Sebastian's words confused Yuan even further.

"Why does she have to pick between me and her family?"

"As I'd said, the Young Lady's freedom is only temporary. Once she has to return to the family, she will most likely lose that freedom again and return to being alone or live with another family, which means that she will no longer be able to see you again, and the Young Lady won't accept that, so she might decide to leave the family, which will cause many problems."

Yuan was speechless. Why must a family become more complicated the more powerful they become? Why would they take away Chu Liuxiang's freedom? Why won't she be able to see him again? He cannot see how this would benefit anyone.

Sebastian then continued, "Therefore, you must make a decision. If you want to stay with the Young Lady, then you should prepare yourself for the future and become more influential so that you can affect even the Chu Family. You may be a little famous right now, but it's not nearly enough to truly affect the world and those that stand at the top."

"However, if you don't intend on doing that, then I suggest you separate from the Young Lady as soon as possible so that neither of you gets hurt, especially since the longer you're together, the more difficult it will be for you two when you have to separate."

"You must also understand that I am not threatening you right now, Young Master Yuan. In fact, I am on the Young Lady's side, as I have been ever

since I was assigned to take care of her. I just want you to be aware of the Young Lady's situation, and I don't want her to experience any grievances."

"I have been with the Chu Family for nearly my entire life, so I know how they operate very well. Although there is no doubt that they care deeply for the Young Lady, it is also a fact that she was adopted, so she isn't truly part of the Chu Family. Even if they cannot benefit from her, they won't just throw her away, as they have sacrificed too many resources for her."

After a moment of silence, Yuan said, "I don't know what to say or think of this information..."

"Don't worry, you have plenty of time to think and come to a conclusion, but don't take too long since the Chu Family is sometimes very unpredictable. Anyways, it was nice talking with you, Young Master Yuan. If you have any questions, I will always be available." Sebastian said to him.

Chapter 556 - Chu Liuxiangs Ambitions

Chapter 556 - Chu Liuxiang's Ambitions

Shortly after Yuan and Sebastian left the immortal caves to talk, Meixiu woke up from her sleep to find Chu Liuxiang sleeping in a weird position and Yuan gone.

She didn't think too much of it and went outside, but neither Yuan nor Sebastian was around.

She wondered where they went as she entered the bathroom to clean her face.

And as Meixiu left the bathroom, Chu Liuxiang was coming out of the bedroom with a sleepy expression on her face.

"Where's Brother Yuan?" Chu Liuxiang asked.

"I don't know. He was gone by the time I woke up."

"Is that so..." Chu Liuxiang then entered the bathroom to clean her face.

Once she came out of the bathroom, she saw Meixiu sitting at the table alone, and after pondering for a second, she decided to sit with her.

Meixiu quickly noticed Chu Liuxiang staring at her, mostly because Chu Liuxiang didn't try to hide the fact.

"Is there something on my face?" Meixiu asked her.

"No, I was just thinking that you're very pretty."

To her surprise, Chu Liuxiang actually praised her appearance.

"Thank you..." Meixiu felt a little awkward after hearing Chu Liuxiang's praises.

"Hey, I have a question. What do you think of Brother Yuan?" Chu Liuxiang suddenly asked her.

"What do you mean?" Meixiu raised her eyebrows slightly.

"I am asking what you think of Brother Yuan as a man. Are you interested in him? Or are you already in love with him? I have watched you for an entire day, but I cannot figure it out. Surely, you must have some feelings for him since you have been living with him for so long, and Brother Yuan is a very charming man... in his own way." Chu Liuxiang blatantly asked Meixiu if she loved Yuan.

And sure enough, Meixiu was left speechless by such a question.

But before she could even respond, Chu Liuxiang continued, "Actually, you don't have to tell me since it won't really change my decision."

"Your decision?" Meixiu asked out of curiosity.

"My decision to stay with Brother Yuan for the rest of my life as his wife. I wasn't sure about my feelings at first, but after seeing him again, I am certain that I love him, so I want to be with him—even if I have to leave the Chu Family."

Meixiu's eyes visibility widened after hearing Chu Liuxiang's declaration of love for Yuan, but she was more surprised that Chu Liuxiang had the courage to say such words out loud than the words themselves.

After all, anyone could tell that Chu Liuxiang had intimate feelings for Yuan just by how she acted when around him.

Seeing Meixiu's reaction, Chu Liuxiang smiled and said, "Don't worry, it's not like I am declaring war or anything like that by telling you that I love Brother Yuan. I just wanted to clear your doubts since you seem to question my feelings for him."

Meixiu opened her mouth, but no words came out, as she wasn't sure how she should respond to Chu Liuxiang's words.

Obviously, she had some feelings for Yuan, but she wasn't as bold as Chu Liuxiang to announce that out loud.

"Two... I want two children with Brother Yuan no matter if they are a boy or a girl. That is my dream—or should I say dreams? And I hope to achieve one of these dreams before I have to return to my family."

Meixiu's jaw dropped a little after hearing her words. Does Chu Liuxiang plan on getting pregnant before she returns to the Chu Family?

"Aren't you a little too young for a child?" Meixiu couldn't help but ask.

Although she didn't know Chu Liuxiang's age, they looked to be around the same age.

"Too young? Based on what? I am already an adult, so why must I pointlessly wait to conceive when I am already prepared to have children? In fact, I have heard from others that it's normal for girls at my age to already have their own family in this day and age."

Meixiu was speechless. While it is true that there are many girls out there that have already started their own family at the age of 18 with some being even younger, she still felt that having a child at such a young age would be too much responsibility.

"Listen here, Meixiu. Brother Yuan is a very charming young man with unlimited potential, and I have no doubt that there will be a lot of competition in the future, so it's only logical to strike while the iron is hot! Even if he decides to get another wife in the future, at least I already have a spot in his heart!"

"Wait... You don't mind sharing him with others?" Meixiu was truly speechless now. Is that why Chu Liuxiang doesn't care if she loved Yuan or not?

And if someone asked her, she would definitely prefer having the man she loved all to herself.

"Well... My father has many wives, so I am used to it, and they all seem pretty happy together. Furthermore, it's not uncommon for powerful men to have many wives. Honestly, I don't care as long as I have a place in his heart." Chu Liuxiang said in a calm and clear voice.

By now, Yuan and Sebastian had been away for over an hour.

Suddenly, the door opened, and both Yuan and Sebastian returned to the immortal caves with suitcases by their side.

After their talk, Yuan decided to go with Sebastian to get their luggage since he knew his way around the place much better than Sebastian.

"Good morning, Brother Yuan! You too, Sebastian!" Chu Liuxiang stood up and left the table after seeing their return.

"Good morning, Young Lady," Sebastian said to her.

"You're awake already? I thought you would still be asleep since you have never been good with waking up in the morning." Yuan chuckled.

"That was years ago!" She quickly said.

Meanwhile, Meixiu silently watched Chu Liuxiang acting very intimately around Yuan, but Chu Lixuiang no longer looked as innocent as before since Meixiu is now aware of Chu Liuxiang's grand ambitions!

Chapter 557 - Unable To Focus

After putting their luggage away, Chu Liuxiang and Meixiu changed out of their pajamas before making their way to the restaurant for breakfast.

Once breakfast was done, Chu Liuxiang asked, "Brother Yuan, what are you going to do today?"

"I am going to practice with my sword at the training building. Honestly, that's pretty much all we do here. I am sorry if it's a little boring," he said.

"It's fine. I don't mind it."

After they rested a little after breakfast, they began making their way to the training building.

"I will see you later," Meixiu said to Yuan before making her way to the fourth floor.

Meanwhile, Yuan entered the gymnasium on the first floor and did some warmup with the sword...

"Can I see that sword?" Chu Liuxiang asked him.

Yuan handed the wooden sword to her.

"Oh, it's much heavier than it looks."

"There's metal in the center, so it feels like a real sword."

Chu Liuxiang began swinging the sword around effortlessly, but her technique wasn't the best. In fact, one could even call them choppy and

amateurish, and anyone watching could tell that she was a complete beginner with the sword.

"What kind of training do you do?" Yuan asked her out of curiosity.

"Mostly how to control my spiritual energy. Like this."

Chu Liuxiang held the sword in front of her for a moment before letting the handle go.

However, to Yuan's surprise, the sword didn't fall to the ground and hovered in the air.

"T-This is... Qi Manipulation?" Yuan could tell that Chu Liuxiang was controlling the sword with her spiritual energy so that it wouldn't fall, and this technique greatly resembled Qi Manipulation that can only be used by Spirit Grandmasters in Cultivation Online.

"Qi Manipulation? It's a technique from my family, but they call it Spiritual Control." Chu Liuxiang said.

"Does that mean you also know how to fly?" Yuan couldn't help but ask.

"Fly? That's impossible," she said.

"Really? In Cultivation Online, if you know Qi Manipulation, then you can control the spiritual energy around your body, allowing you to fly."

"Hmm... I'm not sure, but I cannot control the spiritual energy around me—only my own spiritual energy. I can use it to move things from a distance, and it can even deal significant damage, but that's pretty much all it can do. Flying is out of the question," she said.

"Then it's not Qi Manipulation?" Yuan mumbled to himself.

Of course, there is also the chance that it's actually Qi Manipulation, but Chu Liuxiang hasn't reached that level yet.

"Brother Yuan, you're quite strong, right? Do you want to experience for yourself the technique's might? Don't worry, I will hold back."

"Sure." Yuan eagerly nodded.

He then stood a few meters away from Chu Liuxiang like she'd instructed him before putting the sword in front of him in a defensive position.

"Are you ready?" Chu Liuxiang asked him.

"I am."

Hearing such words, Chu Liuxiang took a deep breath and gathered the spiritual energy in her body at her fists.

Once she was ready, she threw a punch at Yuan, but her fist was nowhere near touching Yuan, as they were still a few meters away from each other.

However, Yuan could feel something powerful and heavy slamming into his sword the next second, pushing him back many inches, nearly knocking him off his feet.

"Wow... And that was 'holding back'?" Yuan asked her afterward.

"Yes, I can destroy a boulder the size of a car if I used all of my strength—enough to kill someone," she said.

"Heavens... That's a terrifying technique..." Yuan muttered in a dazed voice.

"It's very powerful, but it also consumes a lot of my spiritual energy, so I can only use it a couple of times before I exhaust my energy," she said.

A few minutes later, Wang Ming entered the gymnasium, and the first thing he did was look for Yuan's figure.

Once he found Yuan, who was speaking with Chu Liuxiang, he approached them.

"Hey, Yuan, you ready for another spar today?" Wang Ming asked him.

"Yes." Yuan nodded.

Wang Ming then glanced at Chu Liuxiang for a moment, almost like he had something to say, but he didn't say anything to her in the end and returned his focus on Yuan.

The two of them began their spar shortly after, and Chu Liuxiang would watch them fight each other a few meters away.

Meanwhile, on the fourth floor, Meixiu was warming up at the still targets.

"Are you okay, Feng?" The instructor approached her and asked her in a concerned voice.

"You haven't hit the red a single time after shooting a dozen arrows, and you even missed a couple of shots. Even if you're just warming up, this isn't like you. If you're not feeling well, you should take the day off, maybe even get checked by a doctor."

"I am fine, instructor. My mind is just occupied by a few things and can't really focus, that's all." Meixiu said, as she would keep thinking about her conversation with Chu Liuxiang this morning.

"If you cannot focus, you should put the bow down and meditate until you can clear your mind." The instructor advised her.

"I shall do that then. Thank you." Meixiu placed her bow down and began meditating near the wall so that she doesn't obstruct the others.

However, when she closed her eyes and tried to clear her mind, Chu Liuxiang's words would continue to resound inside her head.

'What do you think of Brother Yuan?'

'I love Brother Yuan, and I wish to stay with him forever as his wife.'

'I want two children with Brother Yuan— one of them before I have to return to the family.'

'There will be many competitors in the future.'

'I love Brother Yuan... I really love him...'

"Why did you have to show up now?" Meixiu sighed in a low voice when she couldn't get rid of Chu Liuxiang's voice inside her head.

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Chapter 558 - Senior Hong

After spending an hour trying to clear her head, Meixiu finally managed to calm down, and she went to practice the bow to take her mind off everything else.

At the end of the day, the instructor approached Meixiu and said to her, "Senior Hong said to give him a visit whenever you're ready for the bow. Oh, and he also wants you to bring along Player Yuan if he's not busy."

"I will ask him later." Meixiu nodded.

Sometime later, Meixiu returned to the first floor, where Yuan and Wang Ming had just finished their training for the day.

"Yuan, Senior Hong said that he'd like to see us." Meixiu approached them.

"Is this about your bow?" Yuan asked.

.

"Yes."

"Alright. Let's give him a visit after we tidy up our appearances."

"See you tomorrow." Wang Ming said to Yuan before they left the training building and returned to the immortal caves to take a quick shower.

Once they were prepared, Meixiu and Yuan went to the Hong Family's living quarters with Chu Liuxiang and Sebastian following them.

However, they had to ask for directions since they have never been to the place before.

After asking a few people, they finally arrived at the Hong Family's main living quarters, and there appeared to be smoke coming from the back of the massive building.

"Welcome to the Hong Family, esteemed guests. Master Hong is currently in the crafting hall. Allow me to bring you there." The guard there greeted them.

They then followed the guard to the back of the area, where the smoke was coming from.

Once they arrived and entered the building, they could see a half-naked old man with the upper part of his body that was very jacked and refined completely naked and soaked in sweat.

It was Senior Hong, and he was hammering away at the anvil.

Ding! Ding! Ding!

Every time he struck the hot iron on the anvil, the others would feel their hearts pop out of their chest a little.

"Oh, welcome." Senior Hong stopped whatever he was doing when he noticed Yuan and the others.

"It's okay, we can wait until you're finished," Yuan said to him.

Senior Hong laughed and said, "Don't worry, I was just exercising. It's not like I was actually making anything."

"Exercising?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"Anyways, give me a few minutes. As you can see, I am covered in sweat."

Senior Hong then walked outside the building and into this small building that was literally a few steps away from the crafting building.

After Senior Hong disappeared inside this small building, they could hear water splashing a couple of times before stopping.

A few minutes later, Senior Hong left the small building with a fresh appearance.

"Follow me." Senior Hong then led them to another building that was about a minute away from the crafting area.

"This is the storage area. It's where I keep all of our equipment." Senior Hong said as he opened the locked doors before bringing them inside.

"Wow..." Yuan muttered in a low voice shortly after stepping foot inside this building.

Inside the building was a spacious room that was just like the gymnasium, but there were weapons everywhere.

There were weapons stacked on shelves, weapons laying on the ground, and there were even weapons hanging on the walls.

"Our Hong Family handles all of the faction's equipment since crafting is our expertise, and we get to hone our skills while we support the faction, so it's a win-win for us."

"Follow me."

Senior Hong then led them to a secluded section in the building, and he said to Meixiu, "There are over 100 different types of bows here. Get a feel for each of them and let me know which one you like the best, and I will craft you a brand new one with your strength in mind."

"And judging by your skills at the competition, I would say that you're the type to wield a short bow that specializes in rapid-fire, but you should still check out all of the bows before making a conclusion."

"Okay. Thank you." Meixiu said to him before she went to look at the bows.

"Fellow Daoist Yuan, since you're here as well, why don't you also pick a weapon? You're mostly a sword user, right? We have plenty of them."

"Really?" Yuan was delighted to hear this since he has been thinking about getting a sword but didn't know where.

"Yes. If you want, I can even craft you a custom sword."

However, Yuan shook his head and said, "Just an ordinary sword is good enough. Thank you."

"Alright. The swords are in Section A by the entrance. Let me lead you there."

Thus, Yuan followed Senior Hong to the area holding the swords.

'Wow...'

Yuan was amazed by how many swords there were in this place. In fact, this is his first time seeing so many swords at once.

"Young lady, if you like, you can also pick a sword." Senior Hong didn't want her to feel left out and said.

"Thank you, but I don't use swords— or any weapons for that matter."

Senior Hong nodded and didn't say anything else.

Yuan proceeded to pick up every sword to feel them in his grasp.

Once he found the perfect sword that felt the best in his grasp, he showed it to Senior Hong.

"I want this sword."

Senior Hong nodded without any hesitation, "It may be an ordinary sword, but it's still a good sword nevertheless."

Now that Yuan had a sword, they returned to Meixiu's side.

"Take your time," Yuan said to her.

Meixiu nodded.

Half an hour later, Meixiu said to Senior Hong, "I like the way this bow feels in my hand, but it's a little too light. Can you make me something heavier?"

In fact, due to her increased strength, every single bow that she has used up to this point was simply too light, and that isn't good in archery. In other words, Meixiu has been at a disadvantage this entire time due to this setback and hasn't shown her real potential.

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Chapter 559 - Too Light

"Too light, huh? That's not good. Although light bows are easier to handle, they won't be able to compare to heavier bows in terms of power and speed, just like how a sword shouldn't be too light, sacrificing power for control."

"I will need to conduct some tests to see how strong I should make the bow." Senior Hong said to Meixiu.

"Okay."

"Follow me to the workshop."

Yuan and the others followed him back to the crafting area, where Senior Hong retrieved a couple of dumbbells of different sizes.

"The lightest dumbbell is 100 kilos while the heaviest dumbbell is 500 kilos. Go ahead and try each of them."

.

Meixiu nodded and proceeded to pick up each of the dumbbells, starting with the lightest one.

A few minutes later, Meixiu placed the 500-kilo dumbbell down and said to Senior Hong, "I still think they're a bit too light."

"S-Still too light? The heaviest dumbbell weighs over a ton, you know? Even I have trouble picking it up, and you're only a Spirit Warrior! Just how much innate strength do you possess?" Senior Hong was speechless.

After a moment of silence, he asked her, "What is your limit?"

"I don't know, but I have picked up a car with relative ease before," she calmly responded.

"A car...? How big was the car?"

"Just an ordinary sedan-type car."

"Heavens... These types of cars are usually around 1,500 kilos... And that is still too easy for you? I'm afraid that I won't be able to craft a bow that could handle your monstrous strength..." Senior Hong shook his head in a defeated manner.

He could've never imagined that Meixiu would have such immense strength when her slim figure looked so fragile and weak.

"Anyways, even though I won't be able to make a bow that won't feel 'too light' in your hands, I will still try to craft you the heaviest bow that I can manage."

"It'll take at least a week. I will send someone to notify you when it's done."

"Thank you." Meixiu bowed to him.

Sometime later, Yuan and the others left the Hong Family's living quarters and returned to the immortal caves.

After resting for a little, they went to the Silver Restaurant for dinner.

Once dinner was finished, they took another quick shower before going to bed.

However, when Chu Liuxiang came out of the bathroom after her shower, her appearance made both Yuan and Meixiu speechless.

"What do you think of my pajamas, Brother Yuan?" Chu Liuxiang showed off her one-piece pajamas shaped like a dress, but it was see-through, meaning that they were able to see her skin and her undergarments very clearly underneath.

'What kind of pajamas is that? You might as well be naked!' Meixiu cried inwardly when she saw Chu Liuxiang's daring and shameless pajamas.

"They look... very unique..." Yuan responded after a moment of silence.

And he continued, "Do you always sleep in that kind of clothing? You're basically asking to catch a cold in that."

Chu Liuxiang giggled a little and said, "Don't worry, Brother Yuan. These pajamas are actually warmer than it looks, and most importantly, it feels very comfortable."

"If you say so..." Yuan said.

Yuan and the other two entered the bed a few moments later, and Chu Liuxiang attached herself to Yuan the moment they went under the blankets.

"Brother Yuan, can I ask you something?" Chu Liuxiang suddenly asked him.

"What is it?"

"Do you have anyone that you like?"

Meixiu's eyebrows twitched uncontrollably after hearing Chu Liuxiang's question.

And to their surprise, Yuan quickly responded in a calm voice, "Of course."

"I have a lot of people that I like, and you're one of them," he continued in an innocent tone.

"That's not what I mean, you silly. I am asking if you fancy any girls— to the point where you want to spend the rest of your life with them."

"Well, I wouldn't mind spending the rest of my life with you or Meixiu. Does that count?" Yuan asked.

Chu Liuxiang chuckled and said, "I guess that's good enough for now."

And she continued, "One last thing, Brother Yuan. Can you do 'that' to me like you used to before we slept?"

"That?" Yuan had to think for a moment before he realized what she was talking about.

"Alright."

Yuan then turned his body until he was facing Chu Liuxiang.

The next moment, he gave her a gentle kiss on the forehead.

"Are you happy now?"

"Very!" Chu Liuxiang said before also giving him a kiss on the forehead.

"..."

Meixiu looked at Yuan's back with her eyes wide open.

Since Yuan was facing the other way, Meixiu wasn't able to see what they were doing, but she definitely heard them kissing each other, and this made her heart feel like it was being squeezed.

Yuan and Chu Liuxiang went to sleep shortly after, but Meixiu remained unable to sleep.

Eventually, she gave up trying to sleep and spent the rest of the night cultivating inside the room since she didn't want to leave the two of them alone in the room for some reason.

However, she would quickly realize that it was impossible to focus when her heart was beating so nervously.

"Haaaa..." Meixiu released a deep sigh.

'Mother was right... And it didn't even take long...'

Meixiu stopped trying to cultivate and returned to the bed, and she would spend the next few minutes staring at Yuan's sleeping face.

'If I don't do anything...'

Meixiu closed her eyes and took a silent but deep breath.

When she opened her eyes, they were filled with determination.

'Yuan...'

She began moving her arms until they wrapped around Yuan's body under the blanket, essentially hugging him, and she would close her eyes again just in case Yuan suddenly wakes up so she could act like she was moving in her sleep.

And to her surprise, all of her nervousness disappeared very quickly after she hugged Yuan, allowing her to fall asleep very quickly.

The following morning, Yuan would wake up to find his body restricted again, but to his surprise, it wasn't Chu Liuxiang that was restricting him. Instead, it was Meixiu who was clinging to his body, and with her immense strength, it was pretty much impossible for Yuan to break free without doing so very forcefully, so he could only wait until Meixiu wakes up.

Chapter 560 - Polearms

An hour has passed since Yuan woke up from his sleep, but he hasn't been able to move, much less go anywhere because of Meixiu, who was hugging his body with incredible strength.

Fortunately, Yuan only had to wait a few more minutes before Meixiu woke up and realized the situation.

"I-I am sorry!" Meixiu quickly jumped out of the bed when she realized that she had been hugging him while in her sleep.

"It's okay," Yuan said in a calm voice.

"How long have you been awake?" Meixiu couldn't help but ask him.

"I don't know, but I've been awake for a bit now," he responded.

"W-Why didn't you wake me up if that was the case?"

"You were sleeping very peacefully, and I couldn't tell myself to wake you up in that state."

Meixiu blushed after hearing his words.

'Does this mean he has been watching my sleeping face this entire time?' she wondered inwardly.

"Anyways, now that you're awake, I can finally use the bathroom," Yuan said as he got off the bed and went to the bathroom.

"Not bad, Meixiu. Looks like you're finally showing your true self." Chu Lixuiang's voice suddenly resounded, causing Meixiu to look at her.

"Chu Liuxiang... It's not like that..." Meixiu refuted in a low voice.

"Who are you trying to fool? As someone who is deeply in love with Brother Yuan, I can tell when another girl is also in love with him. You're not benefiting anybody by lying to yourself."

Meixiu remained silent for a moment before releasing a deep sigh.

"You're right. I love him." Meixiu said as she looked at Chu Liuxiang with a confronting gaze.

Chu Liuxiang smiled and said, "I know."

The two of them proceeded to silently stare at each other without blinking like they were in a staring contest.

After a long moment of silence, Chu Liuxiang broke the silence and said, "I wish you the best of luck."

She then left the bed and made her way outside the bedroom.

'I really don't understand her at all...' Meixiu shook her head afterward.

Sometime later, once they all washed their faces, they made their way to the silver restaurant for breakfast.

After their breakfast, they went to the training building for another day of training.

"Hey, Yuan." Wang Ming approached Yuan with a sword in his hands.

"Sorry, but I won't be able to spar with you today," Yuan said to him.

"Eh? Why not?"

"I already have enough experience with the sword, and I want to practice with the other weapons while I am still here, so I will be going to the other floors today. I am only here to let you know."

"I see. That's fine. I should probably take a few days off too." Wang Ming nodded.

"Well, let me know when you feel like sparring again."

"Okay."

Yuan left the first floor shortly after and went to the third floor since the second floor is also meant for swords.

Inside the gymnasium on the third floor, Yuan could see many disciples swinging and twirling their spears around like they were performing for a show; it was completely different from training with a sword.

"Hmm? Instructor, isn't that Player Yuan?" One of the disciples there notified the instructor when he noticed the masked man standing at the door.

The instructor, who was a bulky middle-aged man, turned to look at the door, and sure enough, it was Yuan.

He then approached Yuan and said, "You're Player Yuan, right? How may I help you?"

"I'd like to try wielding a spear— or even a staff," he said.

"Have you used one before?"

"No."

"I can teach you the basics if you want." The instructor offered.

"Thank you." Yuan nodded.

"Follow me."

The instructor brought Yuan to one of the main weapon racks there and said, "Pick whatever you want."

Yuan looked at the weapon racks that had many different kinds of polearms and was a little overwhelmed.

"Are they all spears? I don't know which one to choose."

"They are called polearms. A spear is only a variety of polearms. This one here is called a lance, and this one is called a halberd. They all have their pros and cons, but if you prefer something more balanced, I would recommend the staff."

"Which of them is the most popular? And which one of them is best for beginners?" Yuan then asked.

"I'd say the spear since they're lightweight and very flexible. The lance is basically a larger and heavier spear, allowing it to have much more raw power at the cost of speed and control. As for the halberd, they are mostly defensive, and they specialize in disarming your opponents."

"But since you're a beginner, I would recommend training with the staff first since it's basically a spear without the head. Once you're familiar with the staff, you'll also be familiar with the other polearms to a certain extent."

Yuan nodded, "Then I will start with the staff."

The instructor then showed him two different types of staff with one longer and thinner than the other.

"The thinner staff is more flexible and has a longer reach. The other one is shorter and thicker, but it's much easier to control and has more blunt force. If you're looking to practice with the spear afterward, I would recommend the former one. If you want to use the lance or halberd, then I would go for the thicker staff." The instructor said.

"I will start with the thinner one first," Yuan said.

"Alright." The instructor placed the other staff back in the weapon sack before taking Yuan to a more spacious area.

"The first thing you need to learn about the staff— or any polearm for that matter is how to properly hold it. If you don't know how to hold the weapon, you will never be able to use it at its full potential."

"I will now show you how to hold the staff properly."

Yuan nodded and proceeded to focus all of his attention on the instructor.

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Chapter 561 - Polearms(2)

Once the instructor showed Yuan how to hold the staff, he swung the staff around in a slow but precise manner, allowing Yuan to see every single one of his movements more clearly.

A few minutes later, the instructor stopped his movements and turned to look at Yuan before handing him the staff.

"Here. I showed a little more than I was supposed to, but I wanted to give you a grasp of what it means to wield a staff."

After Yuan accepted the staff, the instructor went to grab another one for himself.

"Am I holding this properly?" Yuan asked.

"Yes, that's perfect. Now let's start with the basic movements."

The instructor then executed a single strike with the staff before freezing in that position...

Yuan followed his movements and executed the same strike with perfection.

Of course, it was only a basic movement, so it wasn't that impressive.

"Here's a follow-up."

The instructor resumed his movements and swung the staff again.

Yuan followed.

The two of them would continue in this manner until they executed most of the basic movements.

"Now try to do it all at once without any long pauses." The instructor said to him.

Yuan nodded and took a moment to remember all of the movements. Once he was ready, he started swinging the staff around with precise and smooth movements.

Although the techniques were the basics, they looked like it was performed by an expert.

'This guy...' The instructor was amazed by how fast of a learner Yuan was.

It had only been a few minutes since they started, yet Yuan was already performing like he was an expert.

"How did I do?" Yuan asked the dazed instructor after performing the basic techniques.

"N-Not bad. I don't have anything to say, which is a good thing. Practice like that a few more times and we'll move to the next step."

"Okay."

Yuan began swinging the staff around again.

About ten minutes later, the instructor stopped him and started showing him more advanced techniques.

This continued for the rest of the day.

Meanwhile, on the fourth floor, Meixiu was doing much better than the previous day.

"Looks like you're back to normal. I hope you've solved whatever was troubling you." The instructor said to her.

"Thank you for your concern." Meixiu nodded.

At the end of the day, Meixiu went to the first floor to meet up with Yuan like usual, but when she arrived, Yuan wasn't there.

'Where did he go?' Meixiu looked around while pondering. She couldn't imagine Yuan leaving without her.

When the instructor there noticed Meixiu looking around, he approached her and said, "If you're looking for Player Yuan, he's on the third floor."

"Third floor?" Meixiu tried to recall what was on the third floor, but she completely forgot.

After thanking the instructor for his information, Meixiu went back up to two more floors until she arrived at the third floor.

When she opened the door and entered the gymnasium, she was surprised to see a large crowd gathered at the center of the room.

This instantly piqued Meixiu's interest, so she approached the crowd to see what they were all looking at with such intensity.

Whoosh!

In the center of the crowd, Yuan was in the middle of sparring with a bulky man, both of them wielding a spear.

"Ha!"

The instructor stepped forward to thrust his spear at Yuan, but Yuan perfectly deflected the attack with his own spear and with relative ease.

After defending against the attack, Yuan swung his spear in a wide arc, suddenly stopping a few inches away from the man's body, barely missing him due to how flexible the spear was.

"You win... Again." The bulky man lowered his spear with a defeated smile on his face, but one could see clear excitement within his eyes.

"Thank you for the experience." Yuan lowered his spear and clasped his hand to the instructor.

"No, I should be thanking you. It's been a while since I have experienced such an overwhelming defeat." The instructor returned the bow.

"Anyways, are you sure today is your first time using polearms? If that's true... You're truly a monster amongst monsters..." The instructor joked in a serious voice.

"Yes, today is my first time using this kind of weapon. I usually use the sword or dagger... sort of." Yuan confirmed.

"Well, either way, you are now even better than me, an instructor. Besides the Grand Elder, I don't think there is anyone in this place that can match you."

It was at this moment Yuan noticed Meixiu standing in the crowd.

"It's time I go. Once again, thank you for teaching me how to use polearms."

The crowd around them made a clear path when they noticed Yuan walking towards them.

"Let's go home, shall we?" Yuan said to Meixiu, who nodded.

Chu Liuxiang and Sebastian followed them from behind.

"That was an amazing performance today. As expected of you, Brother Yuan." Chu Liuxiang said to him after they left the building, as she'd watched him train for the whole day.

Yuan smiled behind his mask and said, "To be completely honest with you, even though I have never held a staff or spear until today, I felt oddly comfortable with it the moment I held it in my hands, almost like I have used them before. It was like that when I first picked up the sword inside Cultivation Online."

"That's what you call a true genius, Brother Yuan. No matter what you touch, you master it with ease!" Chu Liuxiang said in a cheerful voice.

And she continued, "It was like that back at the orphanage, too. You would learn the harmonica and every single new instrument the same day you got it. Is there anything you cannot learn with ease?"

'Common sense...' Meixiu said inwardly after hearing Chu Liuxiang's question.

Sometime later, they returned home to take a quick shower before heading to the Silver Restaurant for dinner.

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Chapter 562 - Battlefield

After eating dinner, Yuan retired to his bedroom with the other two ladies.

"Good night, Brother Yuan." Chu Liuxiang said to him after snuggling close to him.

Meanwhile, Meixiu took a seat a few meters in front of the bed and started cultivating.

Although she was already a Spirit Warrior and ahead of the majority of people in the world, she didn't want to lose to Chu Liuxiang, who was a Spirit Master.

Yuan fell asleep shortly after lying on the bed, as he was incredibly tired from training today— more so than usual since he wasn't used to training with polearms.

After falling asleep, Yuan found himself in his dream once again, but he was surrounded by a thick fog that blocked all of his vision.

"What is it this time?" Yuan's initial thought was that it was something caused by the handsome man that would often appear in his dreams.

But there was no response.

Whoosh!

Suddenly, Yuan felt something fly past his head, but it was too fast for him to see what that thing was.

Then he felt something dripping down his face.

Yuan subconsciously lifted his hand to wipe his face, and to his surprise, he was bleeding.

Whatever just flew past his head had scratched his face deep enough to bleed.

And before he could make sense of what happened, the fog began clearing away, revealing to Yuan his surroundings.

"T-This is..." Yuan's eyes widened when he realized that he was in a plain.

He was also surrounded by people that appeared to be soldiers, and they were all heavily geared with silver armor and a spear.

Fortunately, they didn't appear to be hostile.

However, not far away from his location, there were thousands of individuals fighting each other in what appeared to be a war zone.

There also appeared to be two different factions. One wearing silver armor like those around him and the other wearing black armor.

"General. What is your command?"

Someone there suddenly said, causing Yuan to turn to look in that direction.

Yuan's eyes widened when he saw the handsome man standing no far away from him, but there was something different about the handsome man this time.

His demeanor and the aura he emitted were completely different from the handsome man he would normally see. In fact, it felt like he was a completely different individual.

After a moment of silence, the handsome man raised the spear in his grasp and pointed it at the battlefield.

"Slay the enemies and leave none of them alive!" The handsome man commanded in a profound voice.

The people around him began roaring with excitement, and shortly after, they started rushing towards the battlefield with intense bloodlust in their gaze.

"Kill! Kill them all!"

The soldiers in silver armor shouted as they rushed into the battlefield and began slaughtering the other faction.

Meanwhile, the handsome man remained standing in his original spot.

Seeing this, Yuan approached him and asked, "Where are we?"

The handsome man turned to look at him before responding in a calm voice, "Can't you tell? We're at war."

"I can obviously see that we're at war, but why are we here? What are you trying to show me today?" Yuan asked, thinking that this was one of the handsome man's schemes.

"Today? You're acting like we have met before." The handsome man said with a mysterious smile on his face.

"What?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

However, the handsome man didn't continue speaking after that.

Instead, he turned to look at the battlefield for a moment before rushing into it himself.

When the soldiers wearing that black armor noticed the handsome man entering the battlefield, they immediately focused on him, quickly surrounding him.

However, despite their general getting surrounded by the enemies, the soldiers in the silver armor didn't try to help the handsome man. Hell, they weren't even looking in his direction, almost like they couldn't care less about his situation.

Shortly after surrounding the handsome man, the black-armored soldiers began their assault with all of them lunging at the handsome man from all directions.

The handsome man sneered in a cold manner before swinging the silver spear in his grasp in a full circle.

WHOOSH!

A single swing of his spear created a powerful tornado that instantly consumed the people surrounding him, tearing their armors and bodies apart with ease.

The tornado quickly turned red with how many people it killed in a short time, and it would make the battlefield rain blood and mutilated corpses, creating a gruesome scene.

When the soldiers wearing the black armor saw how the handsome man slaughtered half of their army with a single strike, they immediately dropped their weapons and began fleeing.

"There's no way we can defeat such a monster!"

"I surrender! Please! Spare me!"

A few of the soldiers even started begging for mercy after seeing their army crumble.

However, the silver-armored soldiers completely ignored their enemies' pleas and used their spears to finish off their enemies without mercy.

Once the battlefield was cleared of the black-armored soldiers, the soldiers there gathered around the handsome man and started celebrating their victory.

"Hahaha! Yet another easy victory for the Silver Dragon Army!"

"We'd even given them an hour to defeat our weakest squad!"

"You're simply too powerful, General! With you by our side, we will never experience a single defeat!"

However, the handsome man wasn't celebrating, and he shouted, "It's still too early to celebrate! Until we destroy their entire army and make their lord surrender, the war is still ongoing! Hurry up and get moving!"

The soldiers immediately stopped celebrating and saluted.

"Yes, General!"

The soldiers got on their horses and began chasing after the black-armored soldiers that fled the battlefield— all the way back to their own territory.

It was at this moment Yuan woke up from his dream.

'What was that all about?' Yuan wondered to himself, as the dream was too different from his usual dreams, and even the handsome man felt like a different person.

Chapter 563 - The Aura Of A True Master

After waking up from his strange dream, Yuan went to wash his face before going outside to get some fresh air, and he wondered if he'd been a general in his past life.

"That man in my dreams said that I was his reincarnation, but from what I have seen so far, he appeared to live inside a cultivation world. Does this mean there exists a cultivation world out there somewhere in the universe?"

Many minutes later, Yuan returned inside the immortal caves, and everyone there was already awake and prepared to grab some breakfast.

"Where did you go, Brother Yuan?" Chu Liuxiang asked him.

"I was right outside the caves getting some fresh air," he said.

They left the immortal caves shortly after to get breakfast.

After eating breakfast, they made their way to the training building, where Yuan would spend another day on the third-floor training with the spear. As for Meixiu, she'd spent most of her time in the outdoor training area.

"Instructor, can I train with you again today?" Yuan approached the bulky man who showed a bittersweet smile on his face after hearing Yuan's request.

After all, he didn't want to lose again before so many disciples, and he'd already lost plenty of face from yesterday's loss.

However, as though the heavens were on the instructor's side, before he could open his mouth to speak, someone suddenly approached them and said, "I could spar with you if you'd like."

Yuan turned to look at this individual who'd just spoke, and he was a tall, handsome young man with long hair that was tied into a single ponytail at the back of his head.

'Wow, he's tall...' Yuan subconsciously said to himself when he saw this young man who was definitely an entire head taller than him.

"My name is Shi Lang, and I am an elite disciple. I don't usually train here, but I heard that you'd defeated the instructor yesterday, so I came here today to see if I could spar with you. I promise you that I won't disappoint you." The tall young man continued.

"Oh! Shi Lang! If it's you, you will definitely be able to fight with him!" The instructor said with a gleeful look on his face since he no longer has to fight Yuan.

He then turned to look at Yuan and said, "As you can probably guess from his surname, he's from the Shi Family. If I have to be completely honest, he's even stronger than me, so you'll definitely have fun sparring with him more than sparring with me."

Yuan nodded and said, "Okay, let's spar. By the way, I am Yuan."

"I know." Shi Lang smiled.

The instructor then cleared out an area in the gymnasium for the two of them.

Sometime later, Yuan and Shi Lang stood a few meters away from each other with a spear in their grasp.

Of course, the entire spear was completely made out of bamboo, so they didn't have to worry about accidentally inflicting grave injuries on each other.

With that being said, if struck by the spear, it would definitely hurt, and they could even experience a few broken bones.

Very quickly, a crowd gathered around the two of them before they even started the fight.

"Wow, it's actually Shi Lang. It's been months since I last saw him."

"Shi Lang is number one when it comes to polearms. Player Yuan fought Wang Ming, who is the number one with swords, and won. I wonder if he'll be able to defeat Shi Lang, too."

"No matter how talented Player Yuan is, I don't think he'll be able to defeat Shi Lang. He only picked up the spear yesterday without any prior experience, right? There's no way that he'd win against Shi Lang, who is not only extremely talented but also has 20 years' worth of training."

"I also don't think he'll win, but we won't know for sure until one of them actually wins."

"Whenever you are ready." Shi Lang said to Yuan while standing there in a casual manner.

Yuan readied his spear and got into an offensive position.

"Hm?" The instructor immediately raised his eyebrows when he felt the profound aura that suddenly started emitting from Yuan's body.

Shi Lang also noticed this unfathomable aura, and his calmness was quickly wiped away.

"What is going on? Why am I getting this feeling that I would only get when I fight against my grandfather from him?"

Shi Lang recognized this feeling coming from Yuan, as he would often feeling it coming from his grandfather— the feeling of a true master.

Once Shi Lang got into his position, the two of them would remain standing there without moving for a whole minute.

A minute later, Yuan suddenly moved forward, thrusting the spear in his grasp at Shi Lang.

Whoosh!

Shi Lang quickly dodged this strike that nearly struck him in the chest where his heart was located. However, he'd only managed to narrowly dodge the strike because of how unexpectedly fast Yuan had executed the strike.

An excited yet nervous smile appeared on Shi Lang's face without him realizing it, as it has been a very long time since he has last experienced such thrill and pressure.

After missing his attack, Yuan immediately retrieved his spear and went for another strike that was actually a little faster than his first strike!

Shi Lang dodged this strike again and with more ease despite the increased speed since he knew what to expect after experiencing Yuan's first strike.

Meanwhile, the instructor was shocked to the core after witnessing Yuan's lightning-quick spear thrust that was almost impossible to see with the eyes, and he wondered to himself if Yuan had been secretly practicing with the spear for the whole day yesterday after going home.

'His movements weren't this quick and sharp yesterday! It's almost like I am watching an entirely different person than yesterday! What kind of training did he undergo yesterday? How can someone improve so drastically in less than a day?!' The instructor cried inwardly.

Chapter 564 - Spirit Competition

"Sebastian, what do you think of Brother Yuan?" Chu Liuxiang asked him as they watched Yuan spar with Shi Lang.

"I think he's a very talented young man, perhaps even the most talented person I have ever seen. I dare say that even the top geniuses from the Chu Family wouldn't be able to match him," he calmly responded.

"Then do you think my parents would accept someone like him?" Chu Liuxiang asked, her intentions clear with that question.

Sebastian pondered for a moment before speaking, "Young Lady, you should know very well the Masters' personality. Talent alone won't be enough to impress them. He'll need more than that to receive their recognition."

"Is that so?" Chu Liuxiang mumbled.

Sometime later, the crowd surrounding Yuan and Shi Lang suddenly erupted with cheering and excitement.

"Ooooh! He won! Player Yuan actually managed to defeat Shi Lang!"

"Heavens! What was that technique at the end?! I have never seen anything like that before!"

In the middle of the circle, Shi Lang was sitting on the floor with a look of disbelief on his face.

"What kind of technique was that just now?" Shi Lang asked Yuan.

"It doesn't have a name," he said.

After all, he'd learned the technique from watching the handsome man his dream.

"I see... Anyways, it was a great fight. I didn't actually expect to lose if I am being completely honest." Shi Lang extended his hand for a handshake.

Yuan accepted his hand and said, "Likewise, I enjoyed the spar."

Sometime later, the instructor approached Yuan and said, "You must have practiced a lot even after you went home."

'Training?' Yuan raised his eyebrows, but he didn't respond to that, as he figured that it would be for the better.

"How about another round? I still have a lot of energy." Shi Lang asked Yuan a moment later.

"Sure." Yuan nodded.

And for the next few days, Yuan would spend his time on the 3rd floor mastering the spear and trying out the other polearms.

"Hey, Yuan." Wang Ming appeared on the third floor and called out to him right before he went home.

"Don't forget about the competition; it starts tomorrow."

"Oh, right. I actually forgot about that." Yuan said.

"Where is it being held?"

"Meet me here tomorrow morning about two hours after sunrise. I will take you there."

"Okay."

After returning to the immortal caves, Chu Liuxiang asked, "What competition is being held tomorrow?"

"The top disciples in this faction will be fighting against each other is what I heard," he said.

"So people like that Shi Lang and Wang Ming guy?"

"Yes, there will be more people like them at the competition. I am kind of excited."

The following morning, after breakfast, Yuan went to the training tower with the others.

When they arrived, Wang Ming was already there.

"Good morning, everyone." Wang Ming greeted them.

"Hey."

"How are you feeling today?" Wang Ming asked.

"I am feeling great."

"Perfect. Then follow me."

Wang Ming proceeded to lead Yuan and the others to the location of the tournament.

About half an hour later, they arrive at the plains that had an enormous stage out in the open, and there were bleachers surrounding the platform.

"Wow, there's a lot of people here," Yuan mumbled when he saw the sea of people there, almost like everyone in the Jaded Garden was gathered there.

"Well, it is one of the biggest events of the year, and all of the higher-ups will be here."

"Welcome, Fellow Daoist Yuan." The grand elders approached Yuan the moment they noticed him, and following behind them were a group of middle-aged people.

"Hello."

"Daoist Yuan, allow me to introduce you to a few people." Senior Wang said as she looked at the group of people behind her.

"These are the current heads of the Six Spiritual Family. I believe this is your first time meeting them."

The middle-aged people there proceeded to introduce themselves.

After their introduction, one of them asked, "Daoist Yuan, I heard that you will be practicing in the competition today."

"I will."

"I cannot wait to see you in action. I have heard so many things about you, after all."

"Which weapon do you intend on using?"

"The sword," he responded.

After talking for a couple of minutes, they went to the stage.

"The competition will start in half an hour, but since this is your first time, allow me to give you a brief rundown of the rules." Senior Wang said to Yuan once they sat down.

"There will be a total of 8 contestants including you. Each of you will draw from a box, and those who picked the same number will fight each other. At the end of the first round, the winners will draw again. This will continue until the final round."

"You are not allowed to bring anything but the weapon we provide you onto the stage. Doing so will be an automatic disqualification."

"Besides these rules, there isn't much else to say."

Yuan then asked, "What kind of weapons will we be using?"

"You get to choose the type of weapon you wish to wield on the stage, but none of them will be lethal."

"That makes sense." Yuan nodded.

Half an hour later, one of the family heads entered the stage and called said, "Welcome to our annual Spirit Competition, where our best disciples will face off against each other for the first place!"

"First and foremost, let me call the contestants onto the stage!"

"Wang Ming from the Wang Family!"

"Wang Bingbing from the Wang Family!"

"Shi Lang from the Shi Family!"

"Xi Murong from the Xi Family!"

"Hong Xiuquan from the Hong Family!"

"Li Jinxi from the Li Family!"

"Wu Zao from the Wu Family!"

"Last but not least, Daoist Yuan who is currently staying in the Jaded Garden as a trial disciple!"

The thousands of spectators cheered for the contestants afterward.

"Wow, is that really Player Yuan? This is my first time seeing him."

"He's also wearing a mask out here? Damn it. I wanted to see his face at the very least!"

Chapter 565 - First Round

After introducing the contestants, a servant approached the stage while carrying a small box.

"This is what will decide your matchups. Whoever holds the same numbers will be fighting that round. That is all."

A moment later, the contestants picked their number.

Yuan looked at the paper in his hands.

'Number 1'

"The matches will be in the order of the number, so whoever has number one will be the first to fight," said the announcer on the stage.

"I am first," Yuan said.

The announcer nodded and looked at the other seven. "Who has the other number 1?"

"Haaa..."

Someone there sighed as he raised his hand into the air.

"It's me..." Wang Ming said in a defeated voice.

He turned to look at Yuan and smiled bitterly, "I didn't expect to lose on the first round. What bad luck."

"Everyone but the fighters for the first round please leave the stage!" The announcer said.

Very quickly, everyone but Wang Ming and Yuan left the stage.

"What about our weapons?" Yuan asked.

"They are coming." The announcer said.

A few moments later, two people could be seen walking onto the stage with a sword in their grasp.

"Here you go, Young Master Yuan." One of them approached Yuan and offered him a sword made out of steel, which was out of Yuan's expectation, as he'd expected to be using a wooden sword from the training hall.

However, upon closer inspection, Yuan noticed that the blade of this sword was very dull— so dull that if used to slash somebody, it wouldn't even cut their skin, much less their flesh.

With that being said, that didn't mean the sword wouldn't do any damage, as it could break one's bones if struck hard enough.

"The match will end when either someone surrenders or faints. Stepping outside the stage will also be considered an automatic loss. Lastly, you are not to inflict serious bodily harm on your opponent purposefully." The announcer quickly went over the rules.

"The match will begin when you're both ready."

Wang Ming bowed to Yuan and said, "Please go easy on me."

"Likewise." Yuan returned the bow.

After bowing, they held their swords in front of them.

Seeing this, the announcer said, "Match begins!"

The moment the announcer started the match, Yuan took a step forward and used his movement technique, instantly closing their distance and appearing in front of Wang Ming.

Wang Ming saw this coming after dueling with Yuan many times, so he was prepared for it.

Clang!

The sound of metal colliding echoed in the area as Wang Ming defended Yuan's sword strike.

Clang! Clang! Clang!

The two of them continued to challenge each other without giving themselves any time to rest.

Wang Ming knew that a prolonged fight against Yuan would immensely lower his chances of winning due to Yuan's seemingly inexhaustible stamina, so he could only go all out at the beginning and hope that Yuan makes a mistake.

"Heavens... I have never seen anyone pressure Wang Ming in such a manner! I have heard about Player Yuan's talents, but I didn't think he was this skilled!"

"Look at Wang Ming struggling to defend against Player Yuan's relentless assault!"

"The two of them have been going at each other's throat without taking a second to rest for many minutes now. I don't think this round will last long."

And just like many spectators had predicted, the fight between Yuan and Wang Ming didn't last long, lasting only 10 minutes when Wang Ming got tired and Yuan taking advantage of this, instantly seizing the victory.

"Victor— Daoist Yuan!" The announcer shouted out loud.

"Good fight." Wang Ming bowed to Yuan after the fight ended.

"Good fight."

After the fight, both of them left the stage and went to take a seat at the participants' area where the other contestants were waiting for their turn.

"Yuan, I thought you had been practicing the polearms recently. How come you're so much stronger than our last fight? Don't tell me you practiced in secret." Wang Ming said to him after they sat down.

"No, I haven't picked up the sword in the last few days," he said.

"Then you've been going easy on me this entire time?" Wang Ming looked at him with a look of disbelief.

"That's not it either. I don't know how to explain it, but I definitely wasn't going easy on you before."

"If you say so..." Wang Ming said.

He didn't get the feeling that Yuan was going easy on him when they fought previously, so he trusted Yuan. However, that only made him more curious about Yuan's sudden growth.

'Can someone improve by doing nothing?' Wang Ming wondered to himself.

Meanwhile, the second round started between Wang Bingbing and Hong Xiuquan.

Hong Xiuquan was a handsome young man in his mid-twenties. As for Wang Bingbing, she was a very beautiful young lady also in her mid-twenties.

"She has the same surname as you. Are you two related?" Yuan asked Wang Ming out of curiosity.

"Yes, she's my elder sister."

"You never mentioned having a sister."

"Well, you never asked. Hmm? Are you interested in her? I can introduce you to each other after the competition." Wang Ming said with a somewhat smug look on his face.

"I don't really care, but if you want to." Yuan nodded, misunderstanding Wang Ming's intentions.

On the stage, Wang Bingbing and Hong Xiuquan started fighting shortly after greeting each other.

Wang Bingbing wielded a sword just like Wang Ming, but as for Hong Xiuquan, he had metal gloves around his hands and half of his arm.

"He's using gloves to fight?" Yuan raised his eyebrows when he saw Hong Xiuquan's choice of weapon.

"They are called gauntlets, and they're for people who mainly use their fists to fight, turning their hands into even deadlier weapons. Is this your first time seeing someone using gauntlets?" Wang Ming asked him.

"Yes..." Yuan nodded, and he focused on Hong Xiuquan, as he wanted to see how Hong Xiuquan was going to fight someone with a sword using those gauntlets.

Chapter 566 - Second Round

Ding!

Wang Bingbing swung her sword at Hong Xiuquan, but Hong Xiuquan used his gauntlets to protect himself, using it as a shield.

After defending the attack, Hong Xiuquan used his other hand to throw a powerful punch at Wang Bingbing, who elegantly twisted her body to dodge it.

"Wow, it's like wielding two weapons at once," Yuan mumbled.

"Although he's at a disadvantage due to his very limited range, he more than makes up for it since that allows him to defend and attack at the same time." Wang Ming said.

"Doesn't it still hurt when he defends? Even though he has steel gloves, the impact should still hurt him quite a bit." Yuan asked.

"Yes, but the gauntlets aren't something you just put on and use like a sword or other weapons. It requires the wielder to train their body if they want to use it efficiently. Hong Xiuquan had to temper his body, mostly his arms, to extreme lengths, so that he wouldn't have a broken arm every time he defends."

"He has bathed in treasures since he was young, not to mention the strenuous physical training he does almost every day, allowing his arms and bones to become as durable as steel."

'Body tempering, huh? I wonder how they temper their body... Is it any different from what I did in Cultivation Online? However, this would mean

that treasures with spiritual energy really exist in this world... I should ask them later.'

Ding! Ding! Ding!

Wang Bingbing and Hong Xiuquan fought fiercely for many minutes with Wang Bingbing trying to break Hong Xiuquan's defenses, while Hong Xiuquan tries to catch Wang Bingbing off-guard with a counterattack, but neither of them was successful after many minutes of going back and forth.

"Compared to Player Yuan and Wang Ming's battle, this is kind of boring, right?"

The spectators expressed their boredom 15 minutes into the round since the fight was neither as fierce nor exciting as Yuan's fight with Wang Ming.

Ding!

Eventually, Hong Xiuquan managed to knock Wang Bingbing's sword out of her grasp and outside the stage using his gauntlets.

When this happened, Wang Bingbing surrendered, as there was simply no way that she could defeat Hong Xiuquan without her weapon.

"Good fight." Wang Bingbing bowed to him afterward.

"Good fight, Senior Sister Wang." Hong Xiuquan returned her bow.

However, even though he won the fight, it was actually a very close fight.

If Wang Bingbing had lasted a little longer without losing her sword, Hong Xiuquan would have been the one to surrender since his arms were reaching their limit from defending too many of Wang Bingbing's sword strikes.

Even with his intensive training, it was simply impossible to endure so many powerful strikes from someone of similar talent and strength.

After the match ended, Hong Xiuquan removed his gauntlets, and to everyone's surprise, his arms were swollen and black.

The spectators shuddered at the horrifying sight of Hong Xiuquan's arms, but Hong Xiuquan himself acted like it was ordinary.

"Young Master Hong, do you need treatment?" The announcer asked him.

Hong Xiuquan looked at his arms for a moment before shaking his head, "Nah, I'll be fine. They will recover after some rest, and this is how they usually look after training."

"I-If you say so..." The announcer said in a somewhat baffled voice.

"Heavens... I cannot imagine the kind of training he must endure if his arms look like that at the end of every session." Yuan mumbled in a low voice.

"His training includes smashing large boulders with his bare hands and punching thick steel plates. Bleeding and bruising is a normal routine for him, but the most surprising is his recovery rate. Despite the stress and torture that his body endures every day, he returns a few days later with all of his bruises and injuries gone, almost like they never existed in the first place." Wang Ming explained.

A few minutes later, Shi Lang entered the stage with another young man that appeared to be around the same age.

Shi Lang was handed a spear as Yuan had expected, but the young man named Wu Zao was given a fan.

"Eh? He's a fan user?" Yuan was surprised to see Wu Zao using a fan, as he only knows one other person who uses the fan— his sister, Yu Rou.

"It's a weird choice, right? The fan is one of the least popular weapons due to its extremely short range and small size, so nobody really uses it. Even if somebody decides to pick it up, they are usually women, so it's really rare for a man to pick up the fan as their weapon." Wang Ming said.

And he continued, "If you ask me, the fan has more disadvantages than advantages, and even if someone masters the fan, they will not be on par

with someone who masters the sword or any other more efficient weapon."

"With that being said, Wu Zao has managed to climb to the top ranks with a fan, so he's not someone you can underestimate solely because of his weapon."

Yuan then said, "I know someone that uses the fan in Cultivation Online, but I don't think I have seen her use the fan as a blunt weapon. Instead, she waves it around, sending these destructive and long-ranged attacks at her foes."

"Yes, that is what the fan specializes in— spiritual techniques that require qi. However, that isn't something you can rely on in this world due to our limited techniques since spiritual techniques like that are really rare. In fact, he only knows one spiritual technique."

Once Shi Lang and Wu Zao were ready, the announcer began the fight.

Immediately, Shi Lang used his spear to attack Wu Zao from a distance since it was the obvious thing to do with his huge advantage in range.

Wu Zao didn't panic and used his metal fan to deflect the spear by hitting it at the right spot at the perfect moment, sending the spear to the side.

Once that happened, Wu Zao actually advanced forward and closed their distance.

However, before Wu Zao could get too close, Shi Lang retrieved his spear and swung it sideways, sweeping it at Wu Zao.

Seeing this, Wu Zao held the fan with both his hands to block the strike.

Although he'd successfully blocked the strike, Wu Zao was still sent a couple of steps backward from the impact.

The spectators cheered at their exciting fight even though it had only been a couple of seconds since the match started.

'Wow, I kind of want to fight that Wu Zao...' Yuan thought to himself after he witnessed Wu Zao using the fan with such skills.

"Who do you think will win? Shi Lang or Wu Zao?" Yuan asked Wang Ming.

Although he knew Shi Lang's strength very well after sparring with him many times, he knew nothing about Wu Zao.

"Hmmm..." Wang Ming pondered for a moment before speaking, "Honestly, I have no idea. One might favor Shi Lang due to his immense advantage as a spear user, but Wu Zao is actually more talented and powerful than Shi Lang, so it kind of balances things out... I guess whoever makes a mistake first will lose the entire battle, just like Wang Bingbing and Hong Xiuquan's fight."

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Chapter 567 - Tyrannical Strength

Ding! Whoosh! Ding!

Shi Lang continued his assault on Wu Zao relentlessly, but Wu Zao would always manage to block or deflect the attack.

However, Wu Zao was also unable to close their distance, much less reach Shi Lang to attack him.

"Ha!" Shi Lang suddenly took a large step forward while thrusting his spear, taking Wu Zao by surprise.

"Not bad!"

Wu Zao twisted his body in an odd manner, barely dodging the strike.

After dodging, Wu Zao grabbed Shi Lang's spear with his bare hands, before pulling Shi Lang towards him.

'What incredible strength!'

Shi Lang struggled to retrieve his spear, but he also didn't want to let go of his spear— he couldn't, or that would spell the end for him.

However, that meant Wu Zao could finally reach him.

Seeing that Shi Lang didn't let go of his spear, Wu Zao immediately stepped forward and swung his fan at Shi Lang, who used his other hand to block the fan.

However, Shi Lang didn't temper his body like Hong Xiuquan had, so his arm was immediately bruised by the strike.

Shi Lang endured the pain and used this chance to kick Wu Zao in the stomach, breaking his hold on the spear.

The spectators cheered after realizing what had happened.

"Looks like it will be Shi Lang's loss." Wang Ming said after assessing the situation.

After getting hit in the arm by Wu Zao, Shi Lang could no longer hold his spear properly, and against someone like Wu Zao, that was akin to being crippled.

And just like Wang Ming had predicted, the fight ended shortly after with Wu Zao becoming the victor.

After the match, Shi Lang had his arm checked out, and the doctors told him that his bones were fractured, which wasn't too surprising considering that he got hit by Wu Zao's fan without any protection.

While the doctors treated Shi Lang for his injuries, the fourth round started between Li Jinxi and Xi Murong.

Li Jinxi was a cold beauty with short black hair while Xi Murong was a young man with long black hair.

As for their weapons, Li Jinxi wielded a greatsword that was twice her size while Xi Murong had a small dagger in his grasp.

"Wow, what a matchup." Wang Ming mumbled in a dazed voice.

"Yuan, who do you think will win?" He suddenly asked.

"Uhh... I'm not sure, but I can feel an unfathomable aura coming from that young lady." Yuan said after a moment of silence.

"Well, believe it or not, Li Jinxi is actually the strongest disciple in the entire faction. She has a special body that gives her tyrannical strength. As for Xi Murong... Although he's very talented, he cannot compare to Li Jinxi. This is going to be a one-sided fight." Wang Ming said.

"A special body? Like a physique in Cultivation Online?" Yuan asked.

"Yes, something like that."

Yuan became silent.

This is his first time meeting someone in the real world that has a physique.

Once the contestants were in their position, the announcer started the match.

However, neither Li Jinxi nor Xi Murong moved a single inch after the battle started, both of them silently staring at each other.

"Why aren't they moving?" Yuan asked after waiting for an entire minute.

"Because the first one to move loses. Xi Murong may be quick on his feet, but he cannot defeat Li Jinxi with speed alone, and a single hit from her will spell the end for him. As for Li Jinxi... I guess she just wants to see what Xi Murong intends on doing." Wang Ming said.

After many minutes of silence, Li Jinxi spoke in a nonchalant voice, "How boring. I guess you haven't managed to grow out of your cowardness, Xi Murong."

"Sh—"

Right as Xi Murong opened his mouth to speak, Li Jinxi suddenly dashed at him, forcing Xi Murong to close his mouth to focus on her.

Once she was in range, Li Jinxi swung her large sword at Xi Murong, who quickly turned his body to dodge the incoming attack.

However, Li Jinxi suddenly changed her sword's trajectory midway through her attack, hitting Xi Murong in his sides and sending him flying off the stage like a broken ragdoll.

"Heavens! Did you see how she moved that sword midway?! What kind of movement was that?!" The spectators were shocked by Li Jinxi's display of tremendous strength.

"I can only imagine someone with her physique being able to execute such a ridiculous attack." Senior Wang said with a smile on her face.

"Her sword isn't light either. It requires a tremendous amount of raw strength to change the sword's trajectory after swinging it in such a manner." Senior Li agreed.

And he continued, "You should see how she trains. It's almost barbaric."

After throwing Xi Murong off the stage with a single strike, Li Jinxi casually walked off the stage, and she would look at Yuan while doing so, her gaze seemingly filled with anticipation.

Meanwhile, the doctors rushed to check Xi Murong's condition.

"My lord... Every single bone in his left side is broken." The doctors began sweating profusely after realizing the extent of Xi Murong's injuries.

"Li Jinxi went easy on him, as she could've easily torn his body in half with her monstrous strength," said another.

The doctors quickly placed Xi Murong on a stretcher before taking him to a hospital that was located inside the Jaded Garden.

Meanwhile, the Li Family apologized to the Xi Family for Li Jinxi's actions.

"I'm sorry. Li Jinxi isn't very good at holding back... And she doesn't learn no matter how many times we tell you to do so..." Senior Li sighed.

"Don't worry about it. This happens every time she fights someone," said Senior Xi.

"Well, they say pain is weakness leaving the body. Xi Murong was too reserved today. It was an embarrassment to watch... He also needs to be scolded afterward," said the head of the Xi Family, Xi Murong's father.

Chapter 568 - A Worthy Opponent

"Now that the first round of matches has concluded, there will be a 30-minute break. You may use this time to recover your strength, but you are not allowed to leave the area or consume medicine that speeds up your recovery." The announcer said to them.

The contestants that won their match started to cultivate to recover as much energy as they can, but Yuan merely sat on the benches with Wang Ming sitting beside him.

"You're not going to cultivate?" Wang Ming asked him.

"I don't really need to..." Yuan said, feeling completely fine and overflowing with energy.

"You're really another breed, aren't you..." Wang Ming shook his head with a bittersweet smile.

There was another contestant that didn't bother to rest, and it was Li Jinxi, who barely exerted any strength to defeat her opponent, and she would silently stare in Yuan's direction.

Noticing this, Yuan asked Wang Ming, "She's starring at our direction. What do you think she wants from us?"

Wang Ming turned to look at Li Jinxi and chuckled, "Us? I think she only has you in her eyes at this moment. She's probably wondering if you'll be a challenge for her since she doesn't really have any rivals in the faction, and even the Grand Elders are no match for her."

"What? Even the Grand Elders cannot defeat her?" Yuan was surprised to hear this.

"Li Jinxi may only be at the peak of Spirit Warrior, but her tremendous strength is on another level. In terms of experience and skills, the Grand Elders are definitely above her. However, in a fight, Li Jinxi's superior strength allows her to dominate everyone."

"But it's not like the Grand Elders cannot defeat her. If they fight 10 matches, Li Jinxi would probably win 6 to 7 of them."

"I see..." Yuan nodded.

"I think she will be a worthy opponent for you, Yuan. You'll understand it once you stand on the same stage as her." Wang Ming chuckled.

30 minutes later, the announcer called the four contestants that won back onto the stage for another round of picking numbers.

Yuan looked at his number after picking it.

'2'

"Who has number one?" The announcer asked after everyone picked a number.

"I do." Wu Zao raised his arm, showing the paper with the number '1' in his hand.

"Who has the second one?"

"I do." Li Jinxi said.

"Aiya..." Wu Zao sighed out loud when he realized that Li Jinxi was his opponent.

Although he could defend against Shi Lang's spear attacks with his small fan, Li Jinxi's large sword supported by her immense strength was another story.

"Then I am going to fight him?" Yuan looked at Hong Xiuquan the gauntlet wielder.

Hong Xiuquan was also looking at Yuan while thinking the same thing.

'So he's my opponent, huh...'

"Young Master Yuan, Young Master Hong, please exit the stage so they can fight." The announcer said to them in a respectful tone.

Once they left the stage, Li Jinxi and Wu Zao were handed their weapons.

"This matchup doesn't look fair even in the slightest."

"Right? There's no way Wu Zao can defend against her attacks with that tiny fan."

"Let's just see how he's going to handle this. Hopefully, he doesn't stand there for a few minutes before attacking."

The spectators said to each other.

"Please go easy on me." Wu Zao clasped his hands before Li Jinxi, who merely stood there with a nonchalant look on her beautiful yet cold face.

A few moments later, the announcer shouted, "Fight!"

Li Jinxi rushed at Wu Zao in an aggressive manner the moment the fight started, acting completely different from before.

"Whoa!"

Wu Zao didn't dare to block her attack head-on, nor did he dare to try and dodge her attack normally. Instead, he made sure to stay out of Li Jinxi's range. Every step Li Jinxi took towards him, he would take two steps back. In other words, he was running away.

However, despite running away, Wu Zao didn't dare to show his back to Li Jinxi, so he was running backward.

"C-Calm down, Senior Sister Li! Why do you seem so impatient to finish this match? Let's enjoy ourselves, shall we?" Wu Zao said to her.

Li Jinxi coldly snorted in response, "The faster I deal with you, the faster I get to face that person! I don't want to waste my time with you weaklings!"

"That person? Are you talking about Player Yuan? So you're that confident that he will defeat Hong Xiuquan?"

"Hong Xiuquan cannot beat that person. He's too weak." Li Jinxi bluntly said.

"We won't know that until they finish their fight."

"Are you trying to say that you have a chance of defeating me?" Li Jinxi frowned.

"I-I didn't say that— Whoa!"

Li Jinxi suddenly picked up her speed, chasing Wu Zao around the stage like they were playing tag.

"I was wrong, Senior Sister Li! Have mercy!" Wu Zao cried as he continued running away.

However, the next moment, without waiting for Li Jinxi's response, Wu Zao suddenly changed directions and actually started running at Li Jinxi!

This entire time, he was trying to distract Li Jinxi so that he could take her by surprise.

"Wu Zao, you think I don't know your tricks? You think you can surprise me with such a sloppy tactic?" Li Jinxi didn't even flinch when Wu Zao suddenly started rushing at her, as she had anticipated his plans the moment he started running around.

The next second, Li Jinxi swung her sword horizontally at Wu Zao, giving him no room to dodge.

"Che!"

Wu Zao gritted his teeth and held his fan in front of his body to block the incoming attack.

The instant he felt some pressure on his fan, Wu Zao tried to deflect the attack so that he doesn't need to block all of it.

However, Li Jinxi's strength was simply too overwhelming and was not something Wu Zao could withstand, and the moment he tried to deflect her attack, he was sent flying off the stage just like she did to Xi Murong.

Fortunately for Wu Zao, he didn't actually get hit, so his injuries were relatively minor with a few broken fingers and wrist— at least compared to Xi Murong.

'Damn gorilla monster...! She grew so much stronger since our last fight that was only three months ago! Just what is her body made of? Does she even have a limit?' Wu Zao cursed inwardly as he was brought away in a stretcher by the doctors.

Wang Ming swallowed nervously after seeing Wu Zao fly off the stage.

"Is it just me or did she get a lot stronger... again?" He mumbled in a low voice.

Meanwhile, Yuan held a serious expression on his face behind his mask.

'She's strong... Can I defeat someone like her?' Yuan wondered inwardly, his confidence wavering after witnessing Li Jinxi's inhuman strength.

Sometime later, the announcer called Yuan and Hong Xiuquan onto the stage.

"Are your hands okay? If you cannot fight..." Yuan asked Hong Xiuquan.

After all, he wouldn't feel good about beating someone who can barely use his arms.

"Thank you for your concerns, but I can fight." Hong Xiuquan said.

"If you say so..." Yuan nodded.

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Chapter 569 - Changing Weapons

"Are you two ready?" The announcer asked Yuan and Hong Xiuquan.

"I am." They both responded simultaneously.

"Then let the fight begin!"

Once the fight started, Yuan slowly approached Hong Xiuquan, who was standing still in a defensive position.

His intentions were clear—he was going to repeat what he did during his fight with Wang Bingbing.

'So he's going to defend and try to counterattack, huh? Let's see your limits!'

Yuan accepted his challenge and dashed at Hong Xiuquan with his sword raised.

However, midway through his swing, Hong Xiuquan, who was prepared to block the attack, suddenly shouted with his eyes wide, "I surrender!"

Yuan immediately halted his movements, stopping his sword an inch away from Hong Xiuquan.

"Huh?" Yuan doubted what he'd just heard.

Did Hong Xiuquan just surrender?

The spectators were also dumbfounded by Hong Xiuquan's sudden surrender. They didn't even fight! Why would he suddenly surrender?

"Young Master Hong, did you just surrender?" The announcer asked Hong Xiuquan for confirmation.

"Yes, I surrender." Hong Xiuquan said in a nonchalant voice as he removed his gauntlets before leaving the stage and everyone speechless.

"Why?" Yuan couldn't help but ask him, as he was looking forward to their fight.

Hong Xiuquan stopped for a moment and turned to look at Yuan.

He then said in a low voice, "I lied. My arms are not in the condition to fight."

After a moment of silence, Yuan said, "Then let's fight again after you've fully recovered."

Hong Xiuquan merely nodded his head and didn't say anything else before leaving the stage.

The announcer snapped out of his daze and said, "Young Master Yuan wins by default since his opponent forfeited the match!"

He then asked Yuan, "Since the fight ended before it even started, do you wish to immediately continue onto the final fight, or do you need some time to rest? You're allowed a 30-minute rest period after every match."

"I don't need any rest."

The announcer nodded his head before turning to look at Li Jinxi, who was already approaching the stage.

"Do you wish to immediately start the fight?"

Li Jinxi nodded with an eager look on her face.

Meanwhile, back at the benches, Wang Ming asked Hong Xiuquan, "So, what's your real reason for surrendering the fight? Your arms look fine."

Hong Xiuquan looked at him with raised eyebrows and said, "You're asking me? Didn't you fight against him during the first round?"

"Yes, I did. So what of it?"

Hong Xiuquan frowned and said, "Are you mocking me right now? I didn't even need to block his attack to know that it has a tremendous amount of strength behind it! My arms will literally break if I block it!"

Wang Ming's jaw dropped, and he said, "Surely, you're over exaggerating. I have fought with him many times. There's no way that you wouldn't be able to handle his attacks. Sure, they are powerful, but I can defend against them properly."

"I don't believe that he was using all of his strength against you. I dare even say that his strength is on par with Li Jinxi!"

Wang Ming laughed at Hong Xiuquan's claims, "You're definitely over exaggerating."

"Hmph! Screw you. I'm not going to waste my breath on you any longer." Hong Xiuquan proceeded to ignore Wang Ming, who merely shook his head.

Meanwhile, on the stage, Yuan and Li Jinxi stood a couple of meters away from each other.

"Are you two ready to fight?" The announcer asked them.

"Wait. I have a question." Yuan said.

"What is it?"

"Can I change my weapon?" He asked.

"Your weapon?" The announcer raised his eyebrows.

This is the first time he's been asked such a question.

He then turned to look at the Grand Elders and asked, "Grand Elders, are there any rules regarding changing one's weapon after the competition started?"

"Well, there aren't any rules that forbid the participants from changing their weapons." Senior Wang said.

The announcer nodded and returned to Yuan, "Since it's not against the rules to change weapons, that means you are allowed to do so. What kind of weapon do you want?"

And to everybody's surprise, Yuan pointed at Li Jinxi and said, "I want a weapon like hers."

"Huh?" The announcer looked at him with wide eyes.

"Y-You want a greatsword?" He asked for confirmation.

"Yes." Yuan nodded calmly.

After all, Li Jinxi's sword resembled his Empyrean Overlord more than his current sword that had a thin blade in comparison, and there was simply no way that he would be able to defend against her attacks with such a sword.

A few minutes later, they handed Yuan a greatsword that was just like the one wielded by Li Jinxi.

"It's heavy." The announcer warned him.

Yuan nodded as he grabbed the handle and waved it around casually.

'It's not that bad.' Yuan thought to himself.

The sword itself weighed around 100 kilos, but Yuan was a Spirit Master, not to mention his body that had been strengthened by the golden symbols, so it didn't feel any different than wielding a normal sword.

Of course, both Li Jinxi and Yuan could wield much heavier swords, but that would be an unfair advantage since the others could only wield

weapons at around 50 kilos.

"Since when can he use greatswords?" Wang Ming mumbled to himself.

Although greatswords and long swords are considered as 'swords', they require different techniques to wield properly.

"I am ready," Yuan said after getting comfortable with the sword.

The announcer nodded and started the fight shortly after.

However, neither Yuan nor Li Jinxi moved from their spots.

After a moment of silence, Li Jinxi lifted her sword and pointed it at Yuan.

"Don't disappoint me," she said in a calm voice.

"I will try my best not to," Yuan said.

The next moment, they both moved at the same time, running straight into each other.

"Ha!"

Li Jinxi swung her sword at Yuan with half of her strength to test Yuan's capabilities.

Yuan also swung his sword, accepting Li Jinxi's attack head-on, something most people wouldn't dare to attempt.

Clang!

The air vibrated when their swords collided, causing the spectators' hearts to tremble.

However, neither Yuan nor Li Jinxi moved from their spot.

A cold grin appeared on Li Jinxi's smile when she felt the force behind Yuan's attack, looking like she'd just found her perfect prey.

"Let's dance!" She suddenly shouted, her voice filled with excitement.

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Chapter 570 - Fighting Li Jinxi

Clang! Clang! Clang!

Yuan and Li Jinxi continued to swing their large swords at each other for many minutes, but neither of them was using their full strength just yet, as they were gradually increasing their strength to match each other.

"Heavens... How is he defending against Li Jinxi's attacks head-on? Does he also have a unique physique that gives him tyrannical strength?"

The spectators were shocked to witness Yuan fighting Li Jinxi on equal terms, something none of them have seen before.

"Who do you think will win this fight?" Senior Wang asked the other grand elders.

"Hmm... It's hard to tell. While we know Li Jinxi's full strength, we don't really know Daoist Yuan's full potential." Senior Xi said.

"That is indeed true. For example, I could've never predicted that he had the strength to fight Li Jinxi head-on."

"I wonder if he also has a divine body. Considering how many talents he already has... It's not that crazy of an idea."

"Just what is he made out of? He's the definition of a flawless entity created by the heavens just to mess with everyone else."

Meanwhile, on the stage, Li Jinxi started laughing, "Finally! I have been waiting for someone like you! Someone that I can fight to my heart's content without worrying that you'd die in a single hit!"

Clang!

Yuan was pushed back a full meter when Li Jinxi started fighting for real.

'What a heavy strike!' Yuan cried inwardly, his entire arm shaking afterward, feeling like he'd just struck an immovable mountain.

'What should I do? I am a little behind in terms of raw strength...' Yuan pondered as he looked at Li Jinxi, who was glaring at him like a tiger before its prey.

"What are you waiting for? Are you too afraid to continue? I can tell that you're weaker than me in terms of strength." Li Jinxi said to him.

Yuan remained silent.

There was a good chance that his movement technique wouldn't work on her, who has very keen eyes and a fast reaction, not to mention her weird sword technique that allows her to change her sword's direction at will.

'This is... fun!'

A wide smile appeared on his face, as he has never fought against such an opponent before.

It was at this moment that Yuan felt a surge of energy bursting from somewhere within his body, making him feel like he was invincible.

However, this energy gave him more than just strength and confidence—it also gave him an uncontrollable urge to destroy everything in his path.

And unbeknownst to Yuan, his body began emitting a golden aura that chilled the atmosphere there.

"You..." Li Jinxi's eyes widened when she felt this aura that resembled that of a powerful beast.

"Am I seeing things or is he currently glowing?" Someone asked out loud.

"I see it too."

"What kind of technique is he using?"

"Heavens... My body is shivering uncontrollably for some reason..."

"You too? My body is also shaking..."

No matter who was there, they were all trembling in fear for some reason.

"I have a bad feeling about this..." Senior Wang mumbled in a low voice as she stared at Yuan's still figure.

"..."

Li Jinxi looked at her trembling hands that made it difficult for her to even hold her sword.

'What is this feeling?' she wondered to herself.

Meanwhile, Yuan tightened his grip on the sword, before slowly walking towards Li Jinxi, snapping her out of her daze.

Li Jinxi gritted her teeth to stop the trembling, but when that didn't work, she bit on her lips until it began bleeding, forcibly stopping her trembling with pain.

"Don't get too full of yourself!" Li Jinxi shouted before running at Yuan.

Once she was in range, Li Jinxi swung her huge sword at Yuan.

Clang!

"W-What!?"

Li Jinxi's eyes widened with shock when Yuan defended against her attack with a single hand holding his sword! And he was doing it with seemingly no effort at all!

Li Jinxi was in disbelief, so she tried to overpower him by pressing her sword down with all of her might.

However, Yuan's sword remained as still as a mountain.

"Che!"

Li Jinxi suddenly jumped back to distance herself from Yuan.

"Don't blame me if you get hurt!" Li Jinxi shouted at him before releasing a beastly roar that shook the air around them.

The next moment, her eyes began glowing red with her body emitting a bloodthirsty aura.

Senior Li stood from his seat with a worried expression on his face when he saw Li Jinxi use this unknown technique.

"Aiya! What is that troublemaker doing!? I specifically told her to not use that technique during this competition!" he sighed out loud.

The other grand elders looked at him with their eyebrows raised. This is their first time seeing Li Jinxi use such a technique.

"What technique is she using?"

Senior Li sighed again before speaking, "It's an ancient technique from our family that allows one to increase their body's limits while boosting their overall prowess for a short amount of time. It's a very overbearing technique that nobody in our family has managed to learn since ancient times because our bodies could not handle the stress— at least until Li Jinxi's appearance."

"However, even she cannot control the technique very well. She has gone on a rampage a couple of times after using that technique, and it would take almost every expert in the family to calm her down afterward. We need to prepare ourselves to go down there when she loses control."

"Good lord..." The grand elders were speechless.

'Yuan...' Meixiu looked at his figure with a worried look on her face after hearing Senior Li's words.

Meanwhile, Yuan remained calm despite Li Jinxi's threatening aura.

"Are you ready?" He asked her in a calm voice.

Li Jinxi responded to his question by running at him with her sword raised.

"Let's see if you can handle this!" Li Jinxi swung her sword at him that had enough force to instantly crush a metal ball the size of a large boulder!

Yuan tightened his grip on his sword before intercepting Li Jinxi's attack.

CLANG!

The entire platform shook from their impact.

The next second, Li Jinxi's figure could be seen flying off the platform and into the spectators' area, shocking everybody there.

"Impossible..." Senior Li muttered in disbelief when he witnessed the results.

Not only did Yuan manage to defend against Li Jinxi who had her overall prowess boosted by their family's ancient technique, he completely overpowered her!

"Hm?" Yuan looked at his greatsword afterward, which was snapped in half from the impact.

'What is this feeling?' He wondered to himself as the overwhelming energy in his body began disappearing shortly after the fight.

"W-Winner, Yuan!" The announcer said out loud after realizing that the fight had ended.

The spectators began cheering out loud.

Meanwhile, the doctors went to check on Li Jinxi's condition, who was only knocked unconscious with a couple of minor injuries.

"Young Master Yuan, do you have any words to say?" The announcer handed Yuan a microphone.

Yuan subconsciously accepted the microphone, but he had nothing in mind.

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Chapter 571 - Tribulation

"Uhh... Thank you for letting me fight here today. It was a wonderful experience." Yuan said to the microphone before handing it back to the announcer and walking off the stage.

"Yuan! What kind of technique was that?! I have never seen anyone dominate Li Jinxi in such a manner before!" Wang Ming approached him with a look of disbelief on his face.

"Technique? That wasn't a technique... At least I don't think so." Yuan said.

In fact, even he doesn't know what that power was. It came suddenly and disappeared as quickly.

And even though it gave him incredible strength, Yuan regretted that he wouldn't be able to fight Li Jinxi properly.

'Is there anyone out there that can push me to my limits?' Yuan sighed inwardly.

At this rate, he will have to play Cultivation Online if he wants to fight any worthy opponents.

After the tournament, Yuan regrouped with the others.

"Congratulations, Brother Yuan! You were very handsome on the stage!" Chu Liuxiang said to him.

"Thank you." Yuan nodded.

"Daoist Yuan, what was that golden aura around you? It felt kind of similar to Li Jinxi's technique at the end." Senior Li asked him.

"Sorry, but I don't know." Yuan shook his head.

The grand elders didn't say anything else, as they believed that Yuan wanted to keep his secrets to himself, which was a normal thing to do.

"Regardless, it was refreshing to see Li Jinxi being on the receiving end of the beatdown since she's usually the one beating her opponents." Senior Li laughed out loud despite talking about his own granddaughter.

"Daoist Yuan, it wasn't mentioned during the competition, but the winner is granted a free cultivation technique from either of our Six Spiritual Family." Senior Wang said to him a moment later.

"Now that you mention it, I have yet to take a look at the techniques," Yuan said, as he'd been too busy training.

"It's fine. You have plenty of time."

After talking for a few minutes, Yuan prepared to return to the immortal caves with the others.

However, right as they were about to leave, someone shouted, "I demand a rematch!"

Yuan turned around to see Li Jinxi, who had woken up just recently, standing behind them with an unsatisfied expression on her beautifully cold face, clearly not happy about the results of the match.

"I didn't even get the chance to fight you properly! I demand a rematch!" She repeated.

Yuan then said, "I also wasn't satisfied with the results, but the competition is already over. If you'd like, we can have our rematch on another day."

Li Jinxi remained silent for a moment before nodding her head, "Tomorrow!"

"How about the day after tomorrow? I plan on looking at the techniques tomorrow," he suggested.

"It's a promise!" she said.

"Yes."

Afterward, Yuan left the scene with the others, going straight to the Silver Restaurant for some food before returning to the immortal caves.

After they finished dinner, Yuan tried to activate the golden aura he'd experienced today during his fight with Li Jinxi, but he was unsuccessful.

'Just what was that? How do I activate such a power?' Yuan wondered to himself as he laid on the bed with Chu Liuxiang before falling asleep.

During his sleep, Yuan had a dream.

However, he was alone and surrounded by darkness, almost like he was in the middle of a black hole.

"Where am I?" He wondered out loud.

"Do you seek power?"

A deep voice suddenly resounded, causing Yuan to raise his eyebrows.

"Who's there?" He asked loudly.

"Why else would I be here?" Another voice answered, but it sounded like it was answering to the deep voice, and it sounded like the handsome man from Yuan's dreams.

"Are you willing to sacrifice everything—including your own life?" The deep voice continued.

"I am."

"Then follow me..."

The voices disappeared shortly after, and lights began flickering in the distance, resembling stars, quickly filling the void and turning it into the

starry sky.

Yuan suddenly felt a presence behind him, causing him to turn around.

"It's been a while."

The handsome man reappeared before Yuan again.

"You're really random and confusing, you know that, right?" Yuan said to him.

"I have no control over my appearance, nor do I control your dreams."

After a moment of silence, Yuan asked, "Hey, do you know what that golden aura was today?"

"Of course." To Yuan's surprise, the handsome man immediately acknowledged it.

"What is that power? It filled my body with overwhelming strength, but at the same time, it also gave me an uncontrollable desire to fight. I was barely able to control myself today when I fought Li Jinxi, and that feeling lingered even after the fight, but the power was no longer there."

The handsome man smiled and said, "Do you like it? The feeling of power — the feeling of being invincible. You have just experienced true power today, but that is only a small fraction of its full power."

"That doesn't answer my question. Just what is that power?" Yuan asked again.

"That power is the reason for your existence— our existence. You will eventually remember, but that time is not now, so I cannot answer your question, as I do not know the answer."

"Then do you know how I can use that power again?"

"You're too weak to control that power. The fact you managed to use it today without facing any backlash is already a miracle. Don't worry, you'll

eventually remember how to use it." The handsome man then turned around and disappeared into the void.

However, his voice resounded even after he disappeared, "You should prepare yourself. Your first tribulation will arrive soon."

"Tribulation? What are you talking about?"

"Everything comes with a price, especially power."

The dream ended with that sentence, and Yuan woke up the next moment.

'Tribulation... How am I supposed to prepare myself for something I know nothing about? That's impossible...' Yuan sighed to himself.

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Chapter 572 - Curse

After waking up, Yuan quietly left the bedroom and went outside the immortal caves, but it was still completely dark outside. Clearly, he'd woken up earlier than usual.

He then walked to the small pavilion located right next to the immortal caves and took a seat underneath it.

"Just who am I...?" He mumbled in a low voice.

Although he has pondered about his purpose in life many times throughout his life, he has never once questioned his identity. However, ever since he started having these dreams, he found himself questioning his identity more and more often.

'Who are my parents? Why did they abandon me?'

'Am I really the reincarnation of a powerful cultivator? Or am I merely going crazy?'

Yuan sat underneath this pavilion for an unknown amount of time, silently pondering about his own identity and his reason for existing.

Eventually, the sun began rising.

Ding~

When the sun just peeked over the horizon, Yuan heard a beautiful and familiar-sounding noise coming from somewhere not too far away from him, causing him to snap out of his daze.

"This sound... Someone is playing the zither?" Yuan subconsciously stood up and began following the direction of the sound.

After walking for a few minutes, he arrived in a secluded area behind the immortal caves, where a young woman was sitting on top of a large boulder playing with a wooden zither on her lap, her eyes completely closed.

Ding~

Yuan didn't immediately approach this young woman, as he was afraid of disturbing her, so he stood there quietly, enjoying the young woman's zither performance that was incredibly skillful, comparable to even Fei Yuyan from the Dragon Essence Temple.

The song lasted for a little over five minutes, and once the young woman stopped her performance, she turned to face Yuan's direction, but her eyes remained close.

"Who's there?" She asked in a gentle and soothing voice.

"Sorry, did I disturb you? My name is Yuan."

"Yuan? I am not familiar with your name. Are you new here?"

"Yes, you can say that."

"Then how may I help you? You have been standing there for a while now."

"Your music brought me here. You're playing the zither, right? This is my first time seeing someone playing the zither, and I doubted my hearing at first, so I came here to confirm my suspicions."

"You are familiar with the sound of a zither? How unusual."

"Yes, somewhat. I also enjoy playing the zither, after all."

"Eh? You also play the zither?" The young woman expressed surprise after learning this information.

"Yes." Yuan nodded even though he only touched the zither in Cultivation Online.

"If that's true, why don't you play a song for me, Yuan?" The young woman suddenly offered her zither to him.

It was obvious that this young woman didn't believe Yuan when he said that he also played the zither. After all, the zither is known as a cursed instrument, and she has never met anyone else that would dare to play the zither besides herself.

"Sure."

Yuan approached the young woman and accepted the zither without caring about the curse.

He then took a seat on the soft ground and placed the zither on his lap in a calm and smooth manner.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan began pulling the strings on the zither, playing a song that he'd learned from Fei Yuyan.

"..."

The young woman remained silent throughout the whole song, but it was not because she wasn't impressed. Instead, she was shocked speechless by Yuan's flawless performance.

"What do you think?" Yuan asked the young woman after his performance.

After a moment of silence, she responded in a dazed voice, "W-Where did you learn how to play the zither?"

"I learned it from a friend in Cultivation Online," he answered.

"Cultivation Online...?" The young woman tilted her head, looking a little confused, almost like this was her first time hearing about Cultivation Online.

"You don't know about Cultivation Online? It's one of if not the most popular game in the world right now." Yuan said to her with a dumbfounded look on his face.

He didn't think that there would still be people in this world that hasn't heard of Cultivation Online.

"I'm sorry, but I usually spend most of my time alone practicing the zither, so I don't know much, and I don't play video games." She shook her head.

"Well... Cultivation Online is..."

Yuan proceeded to give this young woman a brief explanation of Cultivation Online and its unique world.

"Wow, it seems like a wonderful game. So there are many zither players in Cultivation Online?"

"I think so. There were a few thousand participants at a zither competition that I also participated in."

"A zither competition, huh? I would love to participate in something like that. After all, no matter how much I enjoy playing the zither or how much passion I have for the instrument, it does get boring when nobody around me dares to even touch the zither, much less play it."

The young woman sighed, and she continued in a bitter voice, "Sometimes it feels like I am the only person in this world playing the zither. However, I am glad that's not the case since you've proven to me that there are others out there that also play the zither. Thank you, Yuan, for coming here today."

"No, I should be thanking you for proving to me that the curse isn't real. I have been told that the zither is cursed in this world, and everyone that plays it will encounter misfortune, but that doesn't seem to be the case." Yuan said to her.

However, the young woman remained silent with a perplexed expression on her face.

After a moment of silence, she said, "About that..."

She pointed at her closed eyes and said, "I don't want to scare you, but I lost my vision shortly after I started playing the zither, and I was born with perfect vision."

"What...?" Yuan muttered in a dazed manner.

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Chapter 573 - Azure

"You sound surprised." The young woman said after hearing his dazed mumble.

And she continued, "Don't you also play the zither? Did nothing happen to you? As far as I am aware, everyone that plays the zither has encountered misfortune that ruined their lives one way or another."

After a long moment, Yuan said, "I... I learned to play the zither inside Cultivation Online, where such a curse doesn't exist. In fact, this is my first time playing with the zither in this world."

The young woman covered her mouth in a shocked manner.

"W-Why didn't you say so before I handed you the zither! And why did you accept it?! Now you'll also be met with misfortune!" The young woman said to him in a worried voice, as she felt responsible for handing him the zither.

Yuan chuckled and said, "You don't have to worry about me. I don't think playing a single song will affect me."

Furthermore, he is already afflicted with many powerful curses, so having another one won't really matter to him.

"If you don't mind me asking, why are you still playing the zither despite the curse that took away your vision?" Yuan asked her afterward.

"It's simple. I love the zither too much to let it go. It can take away my vision, but as long as I get to continue playing the zither, I don't mind some sacrifices," she responded in a calm voice.

Yuan was left speechless by her words.

He has never seen anyone so dedicated and passionate about an instrument before.

If he was in her shoes, he would gladly give up playing instruments for his vision back.

After a moment of silence, he asked, "Then can you tell me a little more about the curse? You said that you lost your vision shortly after playing the zither. How did it happen?"

The young woman shook her head and said, "I don't know. All I know is that I went to sleep one night like usual, but when I woke up the next day, my vision was gone."

"I went to get my eyes checked by many professionals, but to my surprise, all of the doctors said that my eyes were normal and that they couldn't understand why I suddenly lost my vision."

Yuan's body trembled when he heard her explanation, as it sounded oddly familiar for some reason.

'Her situation... sounds exactly like mine...'

Yuan thought to himself, as he could still remember waking up one day with his vision suddenly gone. And just like the young woman, the Yu Family flew him around the world to get his eyes checked by all of the best doctors in the world, but none of them were able to pinpoint the issue.

Eventually, his body also stopped functioning, forcing him to become a cripple who can do nothing but breathe and speak, but can one even consider that as living?

"Have you tried not playing the zither to see if your vision would return?" Yuan suddenly asked.

"I didn't play the zither for a whole year after losing my vision, but the damage was already done, so I decided to continue playing the zither. After

all, I didn't sacrifice my vision just to stop playing afterward. I don't need my vision to play, anyway."

A bittersweet smile appeared on Yuan's face. Indeed, one doesn't need any vision to play an instrument. He knew that very well as someone that was forced to continue playing instruments until he could no longer even lift a finger.

"Aren't you worried that the curse might take away your vision as well?" The young woman suddenly asked him.

"My vision?" Yuan laughed a little before continuing, "It can't take away something that I don't have."

"Eh?" The young woman released a surprised noise.

"You're also blind?" She subconsciously asked.

"Yes. I have been blind since I was young."

"Was it caused by an accident, or...?"

"Nope. Perhaps I was cursed just like you, but I didn't play the zither back then."

"What do you mean 'just like me'?" she asked with her head tilted.

"I also woke up one day to find out that I'd lost my vision."

"I... I don't know what to say..." The young woman mumbled in a low voice.

After a moment of silence, the woman suddenly asked, "If you don't mind, can I touch your face?"

"You want to touch my face? Why?" Yuan raised his eyebrows at her special request.

"I want to visualize your appearance. I can't see, so I have to resort to touching everything to visualize it inside my head," she explained.

Yuan remained silent for a moment.

He then used his divine sense to make sure that they were alone. Once he confirmed that they were the only presence there, Yuan removed his mask and approached her.

"Go ahead."

"Thank you."

The young woman jumped off the boulder and proceeded to feel every inch of Yuan's face with both of her small and soft hands.

It was a little awkward at first for Yuan, but it wasn't anything he couldn't endure, and he quickly got used to it.

"Thank you, I have a pretty good visualization of your face now. You're quite the handsome young man, aren't you, Yuan?" The young woman chuckled a few minutes later.

She suddenly grabbed his hands and placed them on her face and continued, "Here, you can touch my face in return."

"Uhh... I don't really need to do that since I can see your face," he said.

"Eh? I thought you were blind?" The young woman raised her eyebrows.

"I am, but I have another method that allows me to see."

"H-How does that work?" She asked, feeling even more confused.

"It's called divine sense. It not only allows me to see everything perfectly, but I can even see things more clearly and with more details— something that isn't normally possible with the bare eyes," he briefly explained.

"Wow, that sounds wonderful. Do you think you can teach me such a technique?"

"Well... It's not that I don't want to, but in order to use this technique, you will need a very high cultivation base— preferably Spirit Master."

"That's a pity... I am only a Spirit Apprentice."

"Oh, I almost forgot to introduce myself... My name is Azure, and I am part of the Wang Family," she introduced herself.

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Chapter 574 - Promise

"Azure? Is that your nickname?" Yuan asked her, as it was a weird name to have for someone part of the Wang Family.

Azure chuckled like a fairy before speaking, "No, that's my real name. I belong to the Wang Family, but I do not share the same blood as them. In other words, I was adopted, and Azure was what the kids at the orphanage would call me, so I stuck to it."

'She's also adopted?' Yuan's mouth opened a little from surprise.

This is the first time that he can relate to someone so well. Not only were they both orphans, but both of them became sick out of the blue and without any logical explanation, not to mention that they also played the zither.

It was almost as if Yuan was standing in front of a mirror right now.

"Anyways, I have to go now. It was nice speaking with you, Yuan. If you are free in the future, let's play the zither together. I don't normally play outside, but since you're here, I will come outside more often."

"Okay." Yuan immediately nodded.

"How about tomorrow?" She then asked.

"Same time?" Yuan asked.

"Same time."

"Then it's a promise. See you tomorrow."

Azure then picked up her zither and left the place shortly after, but she didn't forget to wave at Yuan before she left.

Once Azure left the scene, Yuan returned to the immortal caves.

"Where did you go? You've been gone all night according to Sebastian." Chu Liuxiang asked him when he returned.

"Hm? I woke up early and couldn't go back to sleep, so I went outside for some fresh air," he said.

Chu Liuxiang raised her eyebrows slightly, but she didn't question him any further.

"What are we going to do today?" She then asked.

"I am going to take a look at the Six Spiritual Families' cultivation techniques and see if they have anything interesting," he said.

Chu Liuxiang shook her head and said, "Brother Yuan, I suggest that you don't accept any cultivation techniques from them."

"Eh? Why not?" Yuan immediately asked.

"Because you'll owe them if you do. Even though you won the competition and are entitled to a cultivation technique, I wouldn't accept anything from them if you do not intend on joining their faction, as that will only make it harder for you to leave them." Chu Liuxiang explained to him.

"That makes sense..." Yuan nodded.

And he continued, "Well, I am mostly going there to see what they have, but I will keep that in mind. I doubt they'll have any cultivation technique that I cannot find in Cultivation Online."

Sometime later, they went to get some breakfast at the Silver Restaurant before making their way to the building that stored the cultivation techniques after asking around for directions.

"This place is smaller than I had anticipated," Yuan mumbled in a low voice as they approached a small pagoda that only had one floor.

"Hello, I am Yuan, and I am here to look at the cultivation techniques," Yuan said to the guards standing in front of the heavily-guarded pagoda.

The guard in the front nodded his head and said, "I have already been notified by the grand elders about your situation. Please, follow me."

However, the guard stopped when he noticed that Meixiu and the others were also following them.

"I'm sorry for the inconvenience, but only Daoist Yuan has clearance to enter the building. The rest of you are not allowed to follow him inside."

After all, Meixiu was only his 'caretaker', and Chu Liuxiang was an uninvited guest at the Jaded Garden. If not for Yuan, Chu Liuxiang would not have been allowed to stay for so long.

"I understand. We'll wait for you out here." Meixiu said to Yuan.

Yuan nodded and said, "I won't take long."

He then entered the building with the guard while the others remained outside.

"What a bummer. I wanted to see how the Six Spiritual Families' cultivation techniques compare to our Chu Family's collection." Chu Liuxiang shrugged.

"Anyway, since we're alone, why don't we have a little chat?" She then turned to look at Meixiu.

"I have nothing interesting to say." Meixiu immediately said.

Chu Liuxiang chuckled and said, "That's perfectly fine. We're going to be talking about Brother Yuan, anyway. Let's start with what we like the most about him!"

Meixiu was speechless. Does she really have to participate in such an embarrassing topic?

Meanwhile, inside the pagoda, Yuan was stunned to see how few cultivation techniques there were in this place.

"Is this all of the techniques on this floor?" Yuan asked the guard as he pointed at the bookshelf in the middle of the room that contained about 20 cultivation techniques.

"Yes." The guard nodded.

And he continued, "Don't let the quantity fool you, Daoist Yuan. These cultivation techniques were not taken from Cultivation Online. They have been with the Six Spiritual Families for many generations now, and before Cultivation Online came into existence, cultivation techniques were incredibly rare."

"That makes sense..." Yuan nodded.

"Hm? Does this mean you guys keep the cultivation techniques acquired from Cultivation Online in a separate place?"

"Yes. They are located in the public library for all disciples to access. Of course, the stronger cultivation techniques are only accessible by higher-ranking disciples."

"As for these cultivation techniques, even if some of them are not as powerful as the cultivation techniques from Cultivation Online, they are greatly valued by the Six Spiritual Families due to their origin and history. Usually, only elite disciples or children directly from one of the Six Spiritual Families are allowed to choose a cultivation technique from this place."

"Anyways, take your time. I will be over here if you have any questions."

"Okay." Yuan then approached the bookshelf located in the center of the room and started looking through all of the cultivation techniques there.

'Oh? Is this the sword technique used by Wang Ming during our first fight? So it was called Sword of Dominance, huh. What a domineering name. Very fitting for such a powerful strike...' Yuan looked at the technique while trying his best to not accidentally learn them as he does in Cultivation Online.

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Chapter 575 - Rematch

'Hmm... Are these techniques too lackluster or am I simply too spoiled by the techniques in Cultivation Online?'

Despite looking through all of the techniques, Yuan didn't find any interest in them.

"Have you found a suitable technique, Daoist Yuan?" The guard asked him when Yuan returned to him.

"No," he shook his head.

"Is there something wrong with the techniques?" The guard raised his eyebrows.

"Not really. I am just not interested in them."

"That's unfortunate. I guess they are too weak compared to Daoist Yuan's techniques. If you ever change your mind, you can come back here at any time."

"Thank you."

After spending about half an hour inside the pagoda, Yuan left the place empty-handed.

"You're out already? That was quicker than I'd anticipated." Chu Liuxiang said when he returned.

"Hm? Where's your cultivation technique?" Meixiu asked him.

"I didn't pick a technique, mostly because I already have more powerful techniques," he said.

"That makes sense... I doubt you'll be able to find a cultivation technique more powerful than Divine-rank in this world."

Yuan shook his head and said, "I don't think the ranks are an issue, since Flying Dagger is only a Mortal-rank technique. I guess I just don't have any need for them, and there's no point in me learning them if I am not going to use them."

"What are we going to do now?" Meixiu then asked.

"Let's just go home for today. I have an appointment with Li Jinxi tomorrow," he said.

"That barbaric girl? Just don't overdo it, Brother Yuan. You were a little bit scary the last time you fought her." Chu Liuxiang said.

"Scary? How so?" Yuan asked.

"Well, you felt like an entirely different person. I was really worried that something might have happened to you."

"I'm sorry for making you worried, but that probably won't happen again."

The next day, they made their way to the Wang Family's living quarters.

"Welcome, Yuan!" Wang Ming went to greet them when he heard that they have arrived.

"Hey, Wang Ming. It feels weird to see you anywhere besides the training building." Yuan said.

"Hahaha... I only go there for you. If you're not there, I have no reason to be there. I mostly spend my time practicing by myself at home," he said.

"Anyways, you wanted to watch my rematch against Li Jinxi, right? I am about to head to the Li Family. You still coming?" Yuan then asked him.

"Of course! Give me a moment. I am going to see if my elder sister would also like to come," he nodded.

Wang Ming then ran off for a few minutes before returning with his elder sister, Wang Bingbing.

"Let me introduce you. This is Wang Bingbing, my elder sister."

"Hello. It's a pleasure to finally speak with you, Senior Yuan." Wang Bingbing bowed to him in a formal manner.

"You can just call me Yuan," he said.

Once they were prepared, they all made their way to the Li Family.

And to their surprise, Li Jinxi was already standing at the gate and waiting for them.

"Took you long enough! I thought you had forgotten about our rematch!" Li Jinxi said to them with a slight frown on her face.

"Li Jinxi, it's still early in the morning, or did you expect us to show up at sunrise?" Wang Ming shook his head.

"Well, I have been standing here since sunrise!" She said, dumbfounding them.

"You're too eager to fight Yuan again, acting like a child the day before the amusement park." Wang Ming chuckled, as he has never seen Li Jinxi acting in such a manner before.

"I dare you to repeat that." Li Jinxi stared at him with an angry look on her face.

Wang Ming immediately regretted making fun of Li Jinxi and took a step back before speaking with a stiff smile on his face, "I-I was only joking, Senior Sister. Please ignore me."

"Hmph!"

Li Jinxi coldly snorted before turning to look at Yuan.

"Are you ready?"

"Yes. Where are we going to fight?"

"Follow me." Li Jinxi proceeded to lead them to a spacious area a few miles behind her living quarters.

"This place... What happened here?" Yuan was dumbfounded when he saw the destructive scene there.

There were crushed boulders and craters on the ground everywhere, looking like multiple natural disasters had occurred in this place.

"This is my training area, so we don't have to worry about making a mess," she said in a calm voice.

Yuan and the others swallowed nervously as they tried to imagine how Li Jinxi trained to make such a mess.

"Oh. You're finally here. Welcome." A voice suddenly resounded from behind them.

They turned around to see Senior Li approaching them.

"I will be present to oversee the rematch just in case the fight gets out of control," he said.

"Sorry for bothering you," Yuan said.

"Hahaha... This is no bother at all." Senior Li casually waved his hand at all.

Sometime later, Li Jinxi handed Yuan a greatsword while wielding one herself.

"Before you start, let's make a few rules. Li Jinxi, you are not allowed to use your berserk technique. As for Daoist Yuan..."

"Don't worry, I won't use that golden aura. Although I cannot control it, I will immediately stop fighting when it happens," he said.

"Alright." Senior Li nodded.

Once they were prepared, Yuan and Li Jinxi began their rematch, and the place quickly became filled with loud noises from their swords colliding with each other.

"Hahaha! This is it! I haven't had a wink of sleep ever since our fight, Yuan!" Li Jinxi laughed as she swung with all of her might.

Bang!

The air shook as Yuan blocked the attack head-on.

"I have also been looking forward to this rematch. Let's do our best!"

Clang! Bang! Clang!

"Heavens... Is it just me or are they even fiercer than they were during the competition?" Wang Ming asked the others in a low voice.

"Now that they are aware of each others' strength, there is no longer any reason for them to hold back against each other..." Senior Li responded with a smile on his face as he looked at the joyous expression on Li Jinxi's face as she fought Yuan.

Chapter 576 - You Can Open Your Eyes

"Haaa!"

Bang!

The ground shook as Li Jinxi struck the ground with her greatsword, creating a large crack in the earth, but she immediately pulled it back out to defend against Yuan's attack.

Dong!

Li Jinxi was sent flying for a few meters before stabilizing herself.

Once she stabilized herself, she immediately rushed at Yuan again.

"How long are they going to keep this up? It's already been three hours since they started fighting." Wang Ming suddenly muttered.

"I think the better question is how much stamina do they have to continuously go at each other in such an aggressive fashion for so long without any breaks. I would have collapsed from exhaustion long ago." Wang Bingbing said.

"Ridiculous strength requires a ridiculous amount of stamina to back up that strength, so it's not unnatural for them to have so much stamina." Senior Li said.

"It's no wonder why she wasn't satisfied after the competition when their match only lasted for a couple of minutes." Wang Ming said.

After fighting for another two hours, Yuan dropped his sword and said, "S-Stop! I-I give up! I am too exhausted to continue!"

He then collapsed onto the ground in a similar manner and began gasping for air.

Li Jinxi stopped moving and stood there with her entire body covered in sweat, looking like someone had poured a few buckets of water on her body recently.

She then stabbed her sword into the ground before falling onto her buttocks.

"Wow... Yuan actually lost to Li Jinxi?" Wang Ming mumbled in a dazed voice.

Besides Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang, nobody there was aware that Yuan had only started moving his body recently after spending many years on the bed as a cripple who couldn't move even a finger. It was already a miracle that he lasted this long.

Meanwhile, Li Jinxi has been training her body ever since she was young, and coupled with her unique physique, it was only natural for her to beat Yuan when it came to endurance.

However, neither of them cared about the result of their rematch, as they were already more than satisfied from the fight itself.

As for Li Jinxi, she only wanted the rematch because she wanted to fight with Yuan, not because she wanted to win.

"Are you both okay?" Senior Li approached them a few moments later.

"Yes... Just... give me... a few... minutes..." Yuan struggled to speak due to exhaustion.

"Take all the time you need, Daoist Yuan." Senior Li chuckled.

In the end, it took Yuan almost half an hour to recover enough energy to stand up again. As for Li Jinxi, it only took her half the time.

"I have never been this exhausted before. You're really a good opponent."
Yuan said to Li Jinxi afterward.

"Likewise, you're the only one who can push me this far." Li Jinxi said.

"If you don't mind me asking, do you temper your body for training?" Yuan suddenly asked her.

"Yes, I do."

"Does that involve bathing in treasures with spiritual energy?"

"It does, but we mostly use herbs and medicine since actual treasures are too rare."

"So treasures really exist in this world..." Yuan mumbled in a low voice.

"Haha... Of course, they exist, Daoist Yuan. If you'd like, I can show you a few later." Senior Li said to him.

"Really?"

"Yes, but I must warn you beforehand that they're not as impressive as the treasures you find in Cultivation Online."

"That's perfectly fine."

Sometime later, they returned to the Li Family's living quarters.

"Daoist Yuan, you can use our bathroom to clean yourself. I will give you some temporary clothes for today." Senior Li said to him.

"Thank you." He nodded.

After Li Jinxi showed him the bathroom, Yuan removed his sweat-soaked clothes and quickly washed his body before entering the large bathtub to relax in the warm water that had been prepared beforehand.

"Ahhh... This feels great, especially after such an intensive workout." Yuan released a deep sigh as he sunk his body deeper into the water

Suddenly, the door to the bathroom opened, and a figure casually walked inside.

Yuan immediately panicked, as he'd removed his mask before entering the bathtub since he didn't expect any visitors.

"W-Who's there?!" He shouted as he turned his back to the door so that they wouldn't be able to see his face.

"Hm? It's just me." Li Jinxi's voice casually responded.

"L-Li Jinxi?"

Yuan quickly used his divine sense, and sure enough, Li Jinxi was the intruder, and she appeared to be completely naked.

"W-What are you doing in here?"

"What else? I was also soaked in sweat after our fight, so I came here to wash myself." Li Jinxi rinsed her body as she spoke.

Yuan was speechless. She couldn't wait until he was done? And surely, they must have another bathroom within these large living quarters, so why did she purposefully pick the one that was already occupied?

After rinsing her body, she began washing her body with soap that gave off a sweet fragrance.

Unbeknownst to Yuan, this bathroom was Li Jinxi's personal bathroom, so nobody uses it besides Li Jinxi herself.

Furthermore, Li Jinxi wasn't the type to be shy, nor does she care about others seeing her body, hence why she showed up even though it was clearly occupied.

However, that didn't mean Li Jinxi would be okay with sharing the bathroom with just anyone, as only those she approves of would receive this kind of special treatment, and in the entire Jaded Garden, Yuan was the only man that she approves of.

After washing herself, Li Jinxi approached the bathtub that had more than enough room to fit 10 people, casually submerging herself in the warm water.

She turned to look at Yuan, who was facing her with his back and said in a nonchalant voice, "I don't care about your identity or your background, so you can relax. Even if I see your face, I won't tell anyone."

After a moment of silence, Yuan turned around and showed his face to Li Jinxi.

Seeing his closed eyes, she continued, "You can also open your eyes. I don't mind if you see my body. I have nothing to be ashamed of, anyway."

"Uhh... I cannot open my eyes... because I'm actually blind." Yuan revealed to her.

"What...?"

As expected, Li Jinxi's eyes widened with shock when she heard this information.

"Y-You're blind? H-How is that possible?" Clearly, she was in disbelief.

After all, how can a blind man move around without any support, much less fight with the powerful cultivators?! That didn't make any sense!

Chapter 577 - Sharing The Bathtub

"Y-You can't be blind! You're definitely joking with me!" Li Jinxi said to him after snapping out of her daze, refusing to believe that she'd been fighting with a blind man this entire time.

"I am serious," Yuan said.

He then opened his eyelids with his hands, revealing his blank eyes that lacked any light to her.

Li Jinxi covered her mouth and mumbled, "T-Then how... How are you moving around like you can see? Nobody would believe that you're blind with how you move around and fight!"

"I can use divine sense, allowing me to see things around me, but I can only see a few meters away from me. However, despite the limited range, I can see things clearer than others," he said.

"Divine sense? I think I have heard of that before in Cultivation Online. To think you can use such a technique in this world as well... You're really something else."

'If word gets out that Yuan is actually blind... Who knows how they will react...' Li Jinxi thought to herself.

After a moment of silence, Li Jinxi spoke, "Hey, you're interested in body-tempering, right? Do you want to try it?"

"Huh?"

"I'm asking if you want to try tempering your body. I always have some medicine and herbs prepared. We can do it right now if you wish."

"R-Right now?"

"Yes. Give me a moment." Li Jinxi then got out of the bathtub and walked to the cabinet located at the corner of the room, retrieving a handful of medicines.

She then returned to the bathtub and tossed all of the medicine in the water.

Once the medicine was floating on the water, Li Jinxi went to press a switch that was at the side of the bathtub.

"The water will get a little hot in a minute. If you cannot endure it, let me know," she said to him as she climbed back into the bathtub.

"Once your body starts to feel a little tingly, start cultivating and absorb the medicine. It's going to be a little painful if this is your first time tempering your body."

"Okay." Yuan nodded.

A minute later, when the water reached almost boiling point, the clear water began turning green, and Yuan could feel a slight tingling sensation all over his body.

He immediately started cultivating and absorbing the medicine in the bathtub, as did Li Jinxi.

'This isn't that bad... In fact, the pain is nothing compared to the bath Feng Feng prepared for me...' Yuan thought to himself.

After all, the treasures that Feng Yuxiang had used for his bath were countless times more valuable than the medicine that Li Jinxi used.

"How are you feeling?" Li Jinxi asked him a few minutes later.

"It's manageable," he calmly replied.

"Good. The medicine should last us about half an hour since there are two of us absorbing the medicine."

The next thirty minutes inside the bathroom was completely silent as Yuan and Li Jinxi tempered their bodies in the same bathtub.

Thirty minutes later, Li Jinxi stood up with her pale skin slightly rosy and said, "The medicine is gone, but if you want to temper yourself more, you can simply put more medicine into the bathtub. I will leave first."

"I will also leave." Yuan left the bathroom shortly after Li Jinxi left, changing into the Li Family's clothes that had been provided to him.

"What do you think?" Li Jinxi asked him afterward.

"I don't know... My body doesn't feel any different once I left the bathtub," he said.

"Obviously. You've only tempered your body for a few minutes. If you want to see some real results, you will need to do that for at least a few hours every day. I'm asking how you feel about tempering your body."

"I would do it every day, but acquiring the medicine to do that is a different story. I don't even know where to obtain the medicine," he sighed.

"If you're worried about not having enough resources, you can speak with the Hong Family. They're the ones who provide us with our medicine. They should also have the solution to your problem." Li Jinxi said to him.

"Okay. I will visit them when I have the chance."

They reunited with the others a few minutes later.

"Where did you go? It's been almost an hour since you went to clean yourself!" Senior Li asked Li Jinxi.

"Yuan seemed interested in tempering his body, so I showed him how to do it, and we ended up tempering our body together." Li Jinxi responded in a casual manner.

"Huh?" Senior Li raised his eyebrows at his granddaughter.

"Y-You what?" Wang Ming looked at them with her eyes wide open.

"D-Does this mean you shared the same bathtub?" He proceeded to ask them.

"Yes, we did." Li Jinxi responded in a nonchalant manner.

The room immediately turned dead silent with everyone there too speechless to respond.

As for Meixiu, although she was surprised to learn that Yuan had shared a bathtub with Li Jinxi, she wasn't worried that they might have done something naughty, as Yuan wasn't the type to do something like that, nor does he have the knowledge to do so.

'Sharing the same bathtub... Even I haven't done that with Brother Yuan!' Chu Liuxiang cried inwardly.

"A-Anyways... What are your plans now, Daoist Yuan? We still have a few hours before it gets dark outside. Do you want to look at the treasures now?" Senior Li asked after snapping out of his daze, trying to change the topic to something else.

Yuan nodded and said, "Of course, and I'd like to visit the Hong Family after looking at the treasures."

"The Hong Family? May I ask what business you have with them? Perhaps I can help you."

"It's about getting medicine to temper my body... Although I would like to start tempering my body, I don't know where to acquire the medicine to do so, and Li Jinxi told me to visit the Hong Family," he explained.

Chapter 578 - Real Treasures

"Medicine, huh? I understand. If that's the case, there isn't anything my Li Family can do for you, as the Hong Family handles most of the medicine in the Jaded Garden." Senior Li said.

"Wow, they must have a lot of medicine if they supply the entire faction..." Yuan said in a surprised voice.

"Haha... After all, they are the ones that require the most medicine because of people like Hong Xiuquan, who tempers his body around the clock almost daily." Senior Li laughed.

"Anyways, follow me. I will show you some of our Li Family's treasures." Senior Li then led Yuan and every one to another room.

"Please wait for a minute while I retrieve the treasures." Senior Li said before leaving them alone in the room.

Even if Senior Li trusted Yuan and greatly valued his presence, there was no way that he'd bring someone that isn't part of their family to their storage area where they keep all of their treasures.

Yuan patiently waited for Senior Li's return, his anticipation high.

About fifteen minutes later, Senior Li returned with three boxes in his grasp.

He placed them on the table before Yuan and the others.

"This is the first treasure."

Senior Li opened the first box, revealing a somewhat dried-up ginseng inside.

"This is... a treasure?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"Don't let its appearance fool you, Daoist Yuan. Try looking deeper." Senior Li said with a profound smile on his face.

Yuan proceeded to analyze the ginseng with his divine sense, and to his surprise, there was a large amount of spiritual energy within the ginseng.

"This is a 1,000-year-old ginseng. And yes, just like its name implies, it's a thousand years old." Senior Li said.

"The only reason it hasn't rotted after so long is because of the spiritual energy within. If we wait another 500 years, it will become a 1,500-year-old ginseng, but that will be its limit. If we keep it for any longer, it will become useless, so we have to use it before then."

"How come it has spiritual energy? How did it grow?" Yuan asked.

"All living things in this world—including animals and plants—have the ability to absorb spiritual energy. This means even the meat and vegetable that you eat contain spiritual energy, but the amount is insanely low—too low to affect anyone, so you cannot become a cultivator no matter how much vegetables or meat you eat."

"The reason is simply that they require a ridiculously amount of time to absorb enough spiritual energy to be qualified as a treasure, and they are usually killed or plucked before they absorb enough spiritual energy."

"Furthermore, just like how humans are not born with equal talents, plants also have their own limit, so it doesn't mean they can become treasures if given enough time."

"Wow... I never knew this..." Yuan mumbled in a dazed voice.

A few moments later, Senior Li opened the second box, revealing a piece of jade slip inside.

"This jade slip also contains spiritual energy? I thought only living things can absorb spiritual energy." Yuan quickly asked.

"Yes, but inanimate objects can also gather spiritual energy. Let me ask you this... What exactly is spiritual energy?" Senior Li suddenly asked him.

"No clue..." Yuan shook his head.

"Spiritual energy is essentially a type of oxygen that you cannot absorb normally, and they grant you more benefit than oxygen if you know how to absorb them. Just like air, they flow through the world, touching everything it passes through."

"Although rare, spiritual energy can sometimes gather inside an object and stay there. Eventually, enough spiritual energy will gather inside the object, turning it into a treasure, just like this jade slip."

"Just like that?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"Yes, just like that. However, they require much more time to become a treasure. Unlike plants that usually take a few hundred years to become treasures, inanimate objects require thousands of years if not tens of thousands of years before they can turn into treasures. This is why most inanimate treasures come from ancient times in the form of antiques and why they're valued more than medicine."

"..."

Yuan was speechless. He didn't think that this world would be so profound and mysterious.

After giving Yuan some time to digest the information, Senior Li opened the third box, which was also the biggest.

"This is... a dagger?" Yuan muttered in a surprised voice when he saw the weapon.

Then he said, "But I don't sense any spiritual energy from this dagger. How can it be considered a treasure?"

"Because it's not the spiritual energy that makes this dagger a treasure. Go ahead. Try picking it up." Senior Li urged him.

Yuan nodded and picked up the dagger, and to his surprise, he could feel some sort of energy entering his body, making him feel more confident and powerful.

"Wow, what is this feeling?"

"It's the dagger's aura that you're feeling, Daoist Yuan."

"Aura?"

Senior Li nodded and retrieved an ordinary dagger before handing it to him.

"Go ahead. Try holding this."

Yuan accepted the dagger, but he couldn't feel anything from the dagger.

"That is the difference between an ordinary weapon and a treasure— it's aura, which can make its wielder more powerful."

"As for how they come into existence... I'm sorry, but even I don't know." Senior Li shrugged.

"People speculate that they gather spiritual energy just like inanimate objects, but they somehow can turn that spiritual energy into a unique aura, turning it into a treasure weapon. Honestly, we might never know the truth."

Yuan looked at the dagger with the aura in his grasp.

'Now that I think about it, the weapons in Cultivation Online also give off this feeling. Whenever I wield a weapon, it would boost my confidence. Perhaps an expert in that world might be able to explain this phenomenon.' Yuan thought to himself.

"Thank you for showing me these treasures as well for the lesson. It was very informative and an eye-opener." Yuan said as he placed the dagger back inside the box.

"It was an honor..." Senior Li smiled.

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Chapter 579 - Harvesting Medicine

"By the way, I forgot to ask, but how do you use the treasures?" Yuan asked Senior Li after he returned from putting away the treasures.

"Well, you can consume the ginseng or use it to make medicine. As for the jade slip, you simply absorb the spiritual energy within," he said.

"I see..."

Sometime later, Yuan and the others left the Li Family's living quarters.

"Li Jinxi, show them the way to the Hong Family. We also need to restock our medicine." Senior Li said to her.

"I understand."

Thus, Li Jinxi led them to the Hong Family.

"Hm? Daoist Yuan? What brings you to the Hong Family?" Senior Hong asked him, feeling pleasantly surprised by his presence.

"Hello. I'd like to temper my body, but I don't know where to get the medicine required for it, and the Li Family recommended that I speak with your family." Yuan said.

"I see. You came at the perfect time. Our family is currently harvesting this month's medicine supply," Senior Hong said.

"Harvesting?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"So you grow your own medicine?"

"Yes. Follow me."

Senior Hong then led Yuan and the others to a few miles behind their living quarters, where a large medicine farm was located.

"Wow..." Yuan mumbled, feeling awed from the medicine farm that stretched to the horizon.

"Every month, we harvest around 100 kilos of medicine from this place." Senior Hong said.

"How does it work? Farming medicine, that is." Yuan asked.

"It's quite simple, actually. We pour a special liquid into the soil and wait until it grows."

"A special liquid?"

"Yes. The liquid is a mixture of other medicine, but that's not even the most important part. In order to grow these medicine, we need a special kind of soil that can only be found in areas with a dense amount of spiritual energy. Without the soil, the medicine will die before they are ready for harvest."

"Would you like to try planting some? After harvesting, we obviously need to plant more." Senior Hong suddenly asked him.

"Of course!" Yuan eagerly nodded.

After watching the medicine being harvested for a couple of minutes, Yuan asked, "Do we need to do anything special when we harvest them?"

"No. You simply cut the leaves off the stem before pulling out the stem so that we can plant more."

"Here, let me show you."

Senior Hong then harvested a few medicines before Yuan and the others.

"Want to give it a try?" He then handed Yuan a pair of scissors.

"Yes."

Yuan accepted the scissor and began harvesting the medicine.

"You're right. It's very easy."

About an hour later, when the harvesting was completed, Senior Hong handed Yuan a bottle of green liquid and said to him, "Watch me."

He then used his own bottle and dripped a single drop of its liquid onto the soil before him.

"That's all you need to do. Try it yourself."

Yuan followed his movements and dropped a single drop of the green liquid onto the soil.

"Now you just wait for them to grow. It takes about three months for the medicine to be ready for harvest. You'll know when they are ready when they have a dark green color."

Once Yuan was satisfied with the information, they returned to the Hong Family's living quarters.

"What do you think?" Senior Hong asked him afterward.

"Well... Even though the process is easy, it won't be possible for me to grow them. Not only do I not have the liquid required to grow them, but I also don't have the soil."

"If you join our family, you can have all the medicine you want to temper your body every day." Senior Hong said with a smile on his face.

Yuan chuckled and said, "Thank you for the offer, but I am still not sure if I want to stay in the faction."

"Is there something preventing you from joining us? Or are we simply not good enough for you?" Senior Hong asked him.

"It's neither of that. I am just having other thoughts. Recently, I have been thinking about creating my own faction," he explained.

"Your own... faction?" Senior Hong looked at him with wide eyes.

If someone like Yuan creates a faction, one can only imagine how powerful it will become in the future.

Meanwhile, Chu Liuxiang looked at Yuan with a joyous gaze.

"Although the Spiritual Elites are great, I want something that feels more personal— something I can call home, and creating my own faction is the only thing I can think of."

Senior Hong nodded and said, "If you actually decide to create your own faction, don't forget about us. We can start an alliance with each other."

"Alliance, huh? I will definitely ask you when it happens." Yuan nodded.

After talking for a little longer, Yuan and the others prepared to leave the place.

"Wait a moment, Daoist Yuan." Senior Hong handed him a basket filled with medicine before he left.

"This should last you a few weeks even if you temper your body every day."

"Thank you, Senior Hong." Yuan happily accepted the medicine.

"And this is for your family." Senior Hong handed Li Jinxi a basket of medicine next.

"Thank you, Elder Hong."

After leaving the Hong Family, Yuan parted ways with the Wang Family and Li Jinxi.

"Yuan, when are you going to return to the training building? I have been itching to fight you." Wang Ming said to him before they left.

"I can try showing up tomorrow," he said.

"Great! Then I will see you tomorrow!"

"I will also be there." Li Jinxi said before leaving.

Yuan and the others returned to the immortal caves shortly after.

"So you're really thinking about creating your own faction?" Chu Liuxiang asked him.

"Yes. I have been thinking about what you told me, and I think that creating my own faction will be the best choice for someone like me."

"Great! When do you plan on creating your faction?"

Yuan pondered for a moment before speaking, "I want to stay here for another week or two... After that, I will make my own faction."

Chapter 580 - Sneaking Inside The Bathroom

After resting for a bit inside the immortal caves, Yuan and the others went to get dinner.

Once dinner was finished, Yuan went to take a bath, and he decided to try tempering his body with the medicine he'd received from the Hong Family.

However, during his tempering, someone opened the door and entered the bathroom.

Knowing that it wasn't a stranger, Yuan didn't panic this time.

However, he was still surprised to see Chu Liuxiang entering the bathroom with nothing but a towel around her body.

"Can I take a bath with you, Brother Yuan?" She asked him.

"I don't really mind, but the water is—" He said.

Before Yuan could even finish his sentence, Chu Liuxiang removed her towel and tossed it to the side before joining the bathtub with him.

Of course, the bathtub in the immortal caves wasn't anywhere close to the size of the one in Li Jinxi's bathroom, so it was a little cramped in the bathtub with Chu Liuxiang's smooth skin rubbing against Yuan's body.

Once the both of them were comfortable, they would sit there in awkward silence.

"We should do this more often." Chu Liuxiang suddenly said.

"I wouldn't mind that if we had a bigger bathtub..." Yuan chuckled.

After another moment of silence, Chu Liuxiang asked, "Brother Yuan, have you ever considered starting your own family?"

"No... I can't say that I have. Why? Do you wish to start a family?"

"Yes, I do." Chu Liuxiang nodded her head with a gentle smile on her face.

She then turned to look at him and continued with a serious expression, "I want to start a family with you, Brother Yuan."

"W-With me...?" Yuan's jaw dropped upon hearing her words.

"You don't want to?" Chu Liuxiang mumbled in a low voice.

"T-That's not it... I just... I don't think I am ready for a family now..."

"It's okay, Brother Yuan. We have plenty of time. You don't need to give me an official answer now. I just wanted you to know my feelings. That's all."

Seeing Yuan's dazed look, Chu Liuxiang suddenly approached his face and kissed him on the lips.

The kiss lasted for only a second before Chu Liuxiang moved back. She then got out of the bathtub and left the bathroom with a slightly rosy face.

Meanwhile, outside the bathroom, Meixiu noticed Chu Liuxiang, who had suddenly disappeared, coming out of the bathroom.

"Y-You were inside the bathroom this entire time? But Yuan is..."

Chu Liuxiang, who had snuck inside the bathroom while Meixiu wasn't looking, smiled and said, "I didn't want to be left out, so I went to take a quick bath with Brother Yuan."

"Unbelievable..." Meixiu was speechless.

"I hope you didn't do anything weird to him..."

Chu Liuxiang chuckled at Meixiu's question.

Inside the bathroom, Yuan laid in the bathtub with a weird feeling in his body, as it was feeling hotter than usual, and even his heart was beating faster.

He could also feel a certain area between his legs becoming stiff.

"Starting a family, huh..." He mumbled in a pondering voice.

About ten minutes later, Yuan also left the bathroom.

When it was time to sleep, Chu Liuxiang snuggled close to Yuan— much closer than usual, which made Yuan more conscious of her.

After falling asleep with difficulty, Yuan encountered the handsome man again.

"Hey, I have a question for you."

"What?"

"Did you... Did I have my own family in the past?"

The handsome man raised his eyebrows, and he said, "As in a wife and children? What do you think?"

"I don't know, that's why I am asking you."

A profound smile appeared on the handsome man's face, and he snapped his fingers, changing the scenery to inside a bedroom.

Yuan looked at the bed, where two figures laid— the handsome man and a naked woman whose face he cannot see because she had her back facing him.

"*email protected#^, I want to start a family with you." The woman suddenly said in a low and nervous voice.

"You should know that's not possible with my situation..." The handsome man sighed.

"Even if you won't be there for us in the future, I want your child. Or am I not worthy to bear your child?"

"It's not about being worthy. I have a lot of enemies, and they will only continue to increase as I chase after my dream. If they know that I have a child... They will target you even when I am gone. I don't want you nor our child to bear such a burden."

The woman snorted, "Burden? I already have plenty of burden as your Dao Companion. A few more won't matter to me. If you don't want to start a family with me, just say so. There's no need to make any excuses."

"I'm sorry..." The handsome man said.

"Hmph! I finally understand why all of your previous girlfriends left you!" The woman got out of the bed and began wearing her clothes in a rushed manner.

"Goodbye!" The woman left the scene in a red face, slamming the door behind her.

"Haaa... There goes another one..." The handsome man sighed after she left.

"Why do I continue getting Dao Companions when this kind of situation keeps on repeating itself? Am I hoping to find someone that is willing to wait for me until I achieve my dreams? As if there are any women out there willing to wait that long..."

Yuan was brought back to the mountain peak after that short flashback.

"So you refused to start a family? Because you are afraid of burdening them? I thought you were strong— strong enough to protect them." Yuan said to him.

"You know nothing, kid. Nobody is born at the peak— not even the ultimate genius. Despite where I ended, I wasn't always strong."

"Furthermore, I was too dedicated to cultivation, so even if I started a family, I wouldn't have any time for them. There's no point..." The handsome man shook his head.

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Chapter 581 - Plain Zither

"Mmmm..." A gentle moan resounded beside him when Yuan awoke from his sleep, and to his surprise, his hands were grasping onto Chu Liuxiang's soft breasts.

He quickly removed his hands, but as he prepared to apologize, he realized that Chu Liuxiang was deep asleep.

Meanwhile, Meixiu was cultivating beside the bed. Ever since she started cultivating at the immortal caves, she'd gained a level, reaching the second level Spirit Warrior.

Yuan silently left the bedroom and went to check the time. Once again, he'd woke up early.

He then went to the bathroom to wash his face before making his way outside, returning to the spot he'd met Azure.

And to his surprise, there was a figure sitting on the boulder with a zither resting beside her, and she was in the middle of cultivation.

Yuan didn't want to bother her and sat down a few meters away from her, silently admiring Azure's elegant appearance.

"You're here early." Azure suddenly spoke a few minutes later, surprising Yuan.

"I woke up early again," he said.

"What a coincidence. I also woke up earlier than usual today. Maybe it's because I have been eager to play the zither with you," she chuckled gracefully.

"Anyways, since we're both here, why don't we play together now?" she then said.

"Sure... Ah, but I don't have a zither."

"That's fine. Follow me. I have a spare one in my room."

Yuan proceeded to follow Azure back to the immortal caves.

Ding~

Every few steps, Azure would pull a string on her zither, creating a single note that would echo in the place.

"If you're wondering why I am doing this, I am using the sound to guide me. Although I cannot see with my eyes, I can see with my zither."

"How does that work?"

"Although you cannot see it, every time a sound is created, it would create an invisible sound wave that ripples as far as it can travel before it disappears, and when this ripple is blocked by something, it would bounce back. I can hear these ripples clearly, allowing me to visualize my surrounding with sound."

"Wow... That's... Really amazing..." Yuan was left speechless by her talents.

"If it were not for this ability, life would've been much more difficult for me."

A few minutes later, they arrived at the immortal caves.

'So she lived on the opposite side of my immortal cave... I'm surprised that we didn't meet until yesterday.' Yuan thought to himself.

"Welcome to my humble home." Azure welcomed him into her immortal cave.

Yuan looked around with his divine sense. The place looked very empty compared to his own immortal cave.

Azure went to her room for a few moments before returning with a plain-looking zither in her grasp.

"I know it looks a little boring, but it plays perfectly. Also, I crafted it myself," she said after handing it to him.

"Eh? You made this yourself? That's amazing."

"Well, it's not easy buying a zither since most of them have been destroyed, and nobody is willing to make them due to the curse, so I could only resort to making my own."

"Does this mean the one you've been using was also made by you?" Yuan asked.

"Yes, and I finished it very recently— about a month ago."

"Anyways, now that you have your zither, let's go play the zither."

"Okay."

They returned to the boulder shortly after.

Once they arrived, they sat down beside each other with a zither on their lap.

"Do you want to go first? We'll take turns playing a song, and once we figure out which song we can play together, we'll do a duet." Azure suggested.

"Sure."

After preparing himself, Yuan began playing a song that he'd learned from Fei Yuyan.

A few minutes later, once Yuan ended his song, Azure began clapping with excitement.

"Wow! Where did you learn such a beautiful song?"

"I learned it from a friend that I met inside Cultivation Online," he said.

"Your first performance is already so good. Are you trying to bully me?" Azure sighed.

"Eh? I'm—"

"I am joking with you." Azure chuckled, and she continued, "But since your performance was so good, I will have to try hard to not embarrass myself."

Azure then took a moment to prepare herself.

Once she was ready, she began playing the zither.

Ding~

Yuan silently watched Azure's performance.

'Wow... She's playing much better than she did yesterday. Besides the Zither Goddess, I don't think anyone else could compare to her...' Yuan thought to himself after witnessing Azure's true potential.

Azure finished her song two minutes later.

"What do you think?"

"It was perfect." Yuan smiled.

"Your turn!"

Yuan nodded and proceeded to play another song.

The two of them continued to play the zither even after sunrise.

"Alright, I think we have played enough for today," Azure said after her song.

"See you again tomorrow?" Yuan asked.

"Of course!" Azure eagerly nodded.

And she continued, "Oh, you can keep the zither."

"Really?"

"Yes. I have no use for it, anyway."

"Thank you!"

Yuan returned to the immortal cave shortly after to get breakfast with the others.

After breakfast, they made their way to the training hall, where Yuan would spend the rest of the day sparring with Wang Ming and Li Jinxi.

"Heavens... This is my first time seeing Li Jinxi in the training hall." The disciples there were shocked to see their most talented disciple in the regular training area.

At the end of the day, Yuan and the others returned to the immortal caves.

"Yuan, when we visited Senior Hong the other day, he told me that my bow will be ready tomorrow, so I will be going there to pick it up."

"Okay. I will go with you."

The following morning, Yuan went to meet Azure in the usual spot, and as expected, she was there early again.

After spending a few hours with Azure, Yuan returned to the immortal caves for breakfast before heading to the Hong Family to pick up Meixiu's custom bow.

"Welcome back. Have you used the medicine yet? If you did, how was it?" Senior Hong asked Yuan.

"It was great. Once again, thank you for the medicine." Yuan said.

"That's good. Anyways, follow me. The bow is finished."

A few minutes later, they arrived at the crafting area.

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Chapter 582 - Divination

"Give me a moment." Senior Hong went inside the building for a minute before returning with a cart that had a long wooden box resting on it.

"Here's your bow. Check it out."

Senior Hong opened the box, revealing the beautiful black short bow inside.

Meixiu immediately went to pick up the bow, and to her surprise, was it many times heavier than any bow she has wielded before. However, it wasn't heavy enough to where she couldn't use it.

She proceeded to move the bow around trying to get a feel for it.

"What do you think? If the weight isn't right, I can adjust it for you, but I can only make it lighter since that's already the heaviest I can make it."

"The weight is perfectly fine. Thank you for this bow." Meixiu bowed to him in a respectful manner.

"Haha... Don't even mention it. You deserve it. Go ahead, try shooting with it." Senior Hong handed her an arrow.

Meixiu took the arrow and proceeded to shoot it at a nearby tree.

'Even the string feels so different. It's more durable, and pulling back on it gives me confidence for some reason.' Meixiu thought to herself.

Whoosh!

Meixiu released the string once she got her aim, and the arrow flew in a straight line until it hit her desired location.

"Your bow is very heavy compared to ordinary bows, so it can handle special arrows like this one." Senior Hong retrieved another arrow.

This time, it was a black arrow that seemed to be made purely out of metal, and the arrow itself weighed a couple of kilos.

Meixiu used this arrow to shoot the same tree.

Whoosh!

The arrow flew straight at the tree, hitting the first arrow she shot before tearing a hole in the tree.

"It went through the tree..." Yuan mumbled in a dazed voice.

However, despite its ridiculous power, Meixiu wasn't that excited. After all, it wasn't like she could use the special arrow for other things besides showing off.

If she had this bow in Cultivation Online, where she could use the special arrow to fight magical beasts, that would be an entirely different story.

"If you're satisfied with the bow, it's yours. I am supposed to have an urgent meeting with the other grand elders and family heads, so I won't stay here any longer." Senior Hong said to her later.

"An urgent meeting? I hope it's nothing bad." Yuan said.

"Well... Do you remember the calamity that our ancestors had predicted? Apparently, there are signs of it appearing soon," Senior Hong explained.

"Calamity? What's going to happen?"

Senior Hong shook his head and said, "Nobody knows. But if you want to participate in this meeting, you can follow me. If the calamity truly exists, we can definitely use your help."

"I will come." Yuan nodded, as he was interested in this calamity.

'I wonder if this has anything to do with the tribulation...' Yuan wondered inwardly as he followed Senior Hong to another location.

About half an hour later, they arrived at this large building.

When they entered the building, Senior Hong led Yuan and the others into this spacious room where the other grand elders and family heads were already present.

"Daoist Yuan? You're also going to participate in this meeting?" Senior Wang and the others were pleasantly surprised by his presence.

"Yes. I would like to know more about this calamity. Hopefully, there is something I can do to help."

"Thank you. Words cannot express how grateful I am to hear such words." Senior Wang nodded.

Once everyone was seated, Senior Wang spoke, "Since Daoist Yuan is new to the subject, let's start from the beginning."

She then retrieved an old-looking scroll and placed it on the round table.

"This was left behind by our ancestors. It's a divination that predicts a calamity when the whole world starts to cultivate. Take a look at it."

Yuan took the scroll and read it in a low voice.

"When the world begins to cultivate, it will experience a tribulation that will dye the entire world red. When the crystal turns yellow, the tribulation is near. Once the crystal turns red, the tribulation will begin."

"Crystal? What crystal?" Yuan asked afterward.

"Take a look at this." Senior Wang then placed a wooden box on the table before opening it, showing Yuan the fist-sized crystal resting inside.

The crystal was semi-transparent, and it was yellow. However, that wasn't what Yuan was focused on, as there appeared to be a hint of red in the

middle of the crystal.

"This crystal had remained clear for thousands of years, but around the time Cultivation Online was introduced, the crystal began turning yellow. And just two days ago, the center of the crystal turned red." Senior Wang explained.

"What kind of crystal is this?" Yuan asked.

"We're not sure either. We had it looked at by experts, and everyone said it's unlike anything else in this world. It's a one-of-a-kind treasure."

Senior Li then said, "To be completely honest with you, none of us here believed in the calamity until the crystal changed colors, not to mention the perfect timing. I hope it's only a coincidence, but that would be one hell of a coincidence."

"If we don't know what's coming, how can we prepare for it?" Yuan then asked.

"Unfortunately, there isn't anything we can really do besides being alert. That's why we created this faction and began recruiting disciples." Senior Wang shook her head.

"With that being said, we have gathered here today to see if anyone has any suggestions or solutions."

And for rest of the day, Yuan would stay with the Six Spiritual Families to see if there was anything they can do.

However, nobody had a good solution in the end, and despite many speculations about the tribulation, they won't really know until it happens.

"Dying the entire world red... That sounds horrible..." Yuan sighed as they returned to the immortal caves.

Chapter 583 - Stay With Me!

"Brother Yuan, do you think the divination is true? Or is this merely a coincidence?" Chu Liuxiang asked him when they returned.

"I want to believe it's merely a coincidence, but..." A bittersweet smile appeared on his face when he recalled what the handsome man in his dream told him.

"I don't know. I just have a bad feeling about the situation."

Chu Liuxiang shrugged and said, "Well, even if there is a calamity, I'm sure you'll protect us, Brother Yuan."

Yuan smiled and said, "Of course. That is my number one priority."

The following day, Yuan woke up early in the morning again.

"You've been waking up early lately, Yuan." Meixiu suddenly stopped cultivating and said to him.

"I'm meeting up with a friend that I made recently," he said.

"The one who gave you the zither?"

"Yes."

"I see... Have fun."

Meixiu returned to cultivating the next moment.

After cleaning his face, Yuan grabbed his zither and went to meet up with Azure behind the immortal caves.

"Have you heard about the approaching calamity?" Yuan suddenly asked Azure at the end of their session.

"Yes, it's always a hot topic within the family, especially as of recently. Did something happen?"

"Well, the crystal is beginning to turn red, which means the calamity is near... really near."

"Red? That's not good... I hope it's nothing too bad and that it goes away quickly."

"Don't worry, if anything happens, I will do something about it."

Azure chuckled and said, "You sound very confident. It's called a calamity for a reason. If a single person can end it, that would make everyone feel silly for worrying so much about it."

"But since you said that, I will rely on you to protect me when it happens, okay? I am not very strong when it comes to fighting. In fact, you can even call me a weakling."

"Of course. You're my friend. I will do my best to protect you and everyone else— that's why I am trying to become stronger— so that I can protect those dear to me."

"Then it's a promise, Yuan. If anything happens to me, I will haunt you for the rest of your life." Azure spoke in a joking tone.

"I deserve it if that's the case." Yuan laughed.

Sometime later, Yuan said his goodbyes to Azure before going to the training hall with the others, where he would spend the rest of the day training with Wang Ming and the others.

This routine would continue for the next four days, and during this time, Yuan would grow more friendly with Azure, even spending more time with her.

Whenever he was with Azure, his mind would feel at ease, almost like she had this magical aura around her.

"Hey, Yuan," Azure suddenly spoke as she laid on the soft ground beside him.

"What is it?"

"Do you have a girlfriend?"

"A girlfriend... as in a partner? I do not," he calmly responded.

"Then... do you want me to become your girlfriend?"

"Eh?"

Yuan subconsciously turned to look at her with his eyebrows raised.

"I know we haven't known each other for long, but I haven't had this much fun in a long time, nor do I have any friends who can connect with me like you do. We also have a lot of things in common. If you ask me, I wouldn't mind spending the rest of my life with someone like you."

"This is... too sudden. And I won't be staying in the Jaded Garden forever."

"Eh? You're going to leave? When? Why?" Azure sat up in a surprised manner.

"I only came here to learn more about the cultivation world, but I somehow ended up as a trial disciple for the faction. I had planned on staying here for a week to experience life as a disciple inside a faction, and once again, I ended up staying longer than intended."

"I have already decided on making my own faction, and I will be doing that once I leave this place in a few days."

"You're going to be leaving in a few days?! That's too sudden! There are still so many songs we can play together! I want to spend more time with you, Yuan!" Azure said in a dispirited voice.

"I also want to spend more time with you, Azure, but I am afraid that if I stay here any longer, I will no longer be able to leave..." Yuan sighed.

"Then don't leave! Stay with me! I love you, Yuan!"

Yuan was left speechless by Azure's sudden confession, and he recalled how he would have many partners in his past life, but none of them sailed smoothly— at least according to his recent dreams.

"Or is it because you don't really like me? If that's the case..."

"What? That's not it! I like you, I really do, but—"

However, before Yuan could finish his sentence, the ground suddenly began shaking.

It started out as a minor earthquake, but it would grow stronger with every moment until it became a full-fledged earthquake.

"W-What's going on?!"

Yuan had a really bad feeling about this sudden earthquake, and the calamity was the first thing that appeared inside his mind.

"Let's finish our conversation later, Azure," Yuan said to her.

However, as though she couldn't even feel the earthquake, Azure spoke, "Yuan... I love you, I really do."

After saying such words, Azure turned around and ran back to her immortal cave, even leaving behind her zither.

Once Azure left the scene, Yuan also returned to his immortal cave, taking with him Azure's zither.

When he returned to his immortal cave, he found Meixiu and the others standing outside the immortal caves, silently looking towards the sky with dazed faces.

"Are you guys okay?!" Yuan asked them.

"Y-Yes... But the sky..." Meixiu mumbled.

"The sky? What happened to the sky?" Yuan asked, as he wasn't able to see the sky with his divine sense.

"The sky is red, Young Master Yuan," Sebastian responded in a serious voice.

"What? Red? How is that possible?" Yuan exclaimed.

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Chapter 584 - Crimson Sky

"I have never seen anything like this before." Sebastian continued speaking, "Although there were times when the sky looked red, it never looked this red, like the sky is stained with blood."

"Brother Yuan... Do you think this is caused by the calamity?" Chu Liuxiang asked him in a worried voice.

"I don't know, but it's very possible. Let's hurry and find the grand elders." Yuan suggested.

Thus, they began running to the Wang Family's living quarters since they were the closest to the immortal caves.

On their way there, they passed through many disciples, and all of them were staring at the sky with dazed looks on their faces.

"Heavens... It's almost like doomsday is upon us..." One of them muttered out loud.

"This must be the calamity our ancestors warned us about! The calamity is coming!"

"Ahhhh! I don't want to die! At least wait until I find a cute girlfriend!"

Everyone in the Jaded Garden appeared to be panicking, but nobody blamed them.

In fact, it was a chaotic scene everywhere around the world at this moment.

Right as Yuan and the others arrived at the Wang Family, they noticed Senior Wang and the Wang Siblings leaving the gates.

"Senior Wang!" Yuan called out to her.

"Daoist Yuan! Perfect timing! Come with me!" Senior Wang said to him.

"Are we going to meet with the others?" Yuan asked her as they moved.

"Yes. Everyone is already aware of the situation."

Senior Wang then led Yuan and the others to where they had a meeting about the calamity just a few days ago.

As for the audience, it was much larger this time with other people such as Li Jinxi and Shi Lang being present.

"Elder Wang! What's the situation with the crystal?!" Senior Hong asked her the moment they arrived.

"I don't know yet. I haven't had the time to look at it, but we'll all know the answer soon."

Senior Wang then retrieved the box that contained the crystal, and she placed it on the table before opening it for everyone there to see.

"T-That's..."

The people there immediately frowned the next moment when they saw that the color of the crystal had turned completely red.

"When did this happen?" Senior Li asked.

"We have been checking the crystal daily every since it turned yellow, but it wasn't like this yesterday, so I can only assume that it'd turned red very recently." Senior Wang said.

"Sh*t... Not only is the crystal red, but even the sky had turned red!" Someone there cursed.

"Do we know if there are any changes in the world besides the sky changing colors?" Senior Shi asked.

"I have been looking at the news since I woke up, but only the red sky is being reported on. Even now, there is no other news." Senior Xi said.

"Fuck! This is so frustrating! The calamity is almost here if not already here, yet we still don't know anything about it! How can we possibly deal with a situation like this?" The head of the Wang Family cursed out loud.

"For all we know, the calamity could happen on the other side of the world." The head of the Shi Family sighed.

"Somebody bring all of the ancient scrolls over here! We're going to search through all of them and see if there are any clues that we had missed!" Senior Hong suddenly said.

About an hour later, the empty table became filled with ancient scrolls that had been passed down by their ancestors, and they began reading through the scrolls, hoping to find even a single clue about the calamity.

However, after spending half of the day reading through all of the scrolls, they were unable to find any new information.

"It's no use. We will have to wait for the calamity to actually start before we can even start preparing for it." Senior Wang placed the scroll in her hands down before sighing.

"Is there really nothing we can do but wait? What if it's too late by then?" Wang Ming sighed out loud.

"Then do you have any suggestion?" Li Jinxi said to him.

"I don't..." He lowered his head.

Eventually, the gathering was dismissed.

"There is nothing we can do but remain alert. If there is any news regarding the calamity, let one of the grand elders or family head know about it immediately." Senior Wang said to them before dismissing everyone.

Yuan and the others returned to the immortal caves shortly after.

When they returned home, Meixiu received a call from Yu Rou.

"Meixiu! Are you guys okay?!" Yu Rou's worried voice resounded the moment she picked up the phone.

"Yes, we're fine. What about you?" Meixiu said.

"We're also fine, but the red sky is scaring all of us. I cannot help but feel like something bad is about to happen."

"Well..." Meixiu proceeded to give Yu Rou a brief explanation about the situation and the potential calamity that is coming.

"What? A calamity? What's going to happen?" Yu Rou asked, sounding more worried than before she heard the information, and rightfully so.

"Unfortunately, that's all we know. As for the calamity, we won't know until it happens." Meixiu said.

"I really hope it's nothing too bad." Yu Rou sighed.

After talking with Meixiu and Yuan for a few minutes, Yu Rou hung up, as she and the other disciples had been summoned by White Lotus to talk about the current situation.

And for the rest of the day, they would remain inside their immortal caves, patiently waiting for the calamity to show itself.

However, to everyone's absolute surprise, the crimson sky disappeared the following day.

"Does this mean that the calamity had passed, or was it simply a warning?" Yuan mumbled in a low voice.

He also went to the back of the immortal caves to see if Azure would be there like usual, but alas, she was nowhere to be seen.

"How should I respond to her confession?" Yuan sat there and silently pondered to himself until sunrise.

And just as he prepared to return to the immortal caves, another earthquake appeared, and it would last a tad bit longer than the last one, not to mention a little stronger as well.

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Chapter 585 - Ancestors Tomb

Chapter 585 - Ancestors' Tomb

"Another earthquake?" Yuan quickly returned to the immortal caves.

"Is the sky red again?" Yuan asked them when he returned.

"No, the sky hasn't changed this time," Meixiu said after looking outside.

"Is that so..."

Yuan decided to stay at the immortal caves with Meixiu and the others just in case something were to happen, but sometime in the afternoon, Wang Ming showed up at their immortal caves.

"Wang Ming? What happened?"

"Yuan, come with me. We have discovered something new," he said.

"Really? Let's go!"

Wang Ming proceeded to bring Yuan and the others to the Wang Family, where Senior Wang was waiting for their arrival.

"What did you find?" Yuan asked her.

"You probably don't know this since we never mentioned it, but we built this place close to our ancestors' tomb, and according to the people who maintain that place, the spiritual energy there has become chaotic and even somewhat menacing. Perhaps there is a clue in that place about the approaching calamity." Senior Wang said.

And she continued, "I will be heading there now with the other grand elders. Do you want to come with us?"

"Of course." Yuan immediately nodded.

"Great. Follow me."

"Hm? You're not coming?" Yuan asked Wang Ming when he noticed that Wang Ming wasn't following them.

"Only the grand elders and family heads are allowed to approach the ancestors' tomb— not including the people that maintain the cleanliness of that place. Of course, you're an exception." Wang Ming said.

"I see..."

"What about us?" Meixiu asked.

Senior Wang looked at them and said, "You guys can come too."

After all, she didn't have the courage to separate them from Yuan, who could potentially be their savior in this unknown calamity.

The ancestors' tomb was only a few miles away from the Jaded Garden, and it took Yuan and the others about two and a half hours of walking before they arrived at the location.

'That's the ancestors' tomb? It looks so familiar to that place...' Yuan thought to himself when he could finally see the ancestors' tomb that somewhat resembled the treasure room inside the Dragon Temple within Cultivation Online.

"The ancestors' tomb was created thousands of years ago, and it's where all family heads and grand elders go to rest after they permanently close their eyes." Senior Wang said to them.

A few more minutes later, they arrived at the front of the tomb, where the other grand elders were present.

"What do you think of this place, Elder Wang?" Senior Hong asked when they arrived.

"It's hard to describe the feeling I am getting, but it definitely feels different than usual," she said.

Senior Hong nodded and said, "You don't feel it now because you're too far away, but if you stand in front of the doors, your body will start to shiver uncontrollably for some reason. That's why we're all standing here, far away from the doors."

"Have you tried entering the place yet?" Senior Wang asked.

The others shook their heads.

"Then let's do that right now— together." Senior Wang then said.

"Uhh... Shouldn't we arm ourselves just in case?" Yuan asked them when they began approaching the tomb.

Senior Wang chuckled and said, "Arm ourselves? Unless the corpses inside suddenly turned into zombies, there's nothing inside. Furthermore, the doors remain closed unless we have to put a new body inside."

"Is that so..."

"Don't worry. If we suddenly need weapons for whatever reason, there will be plenty inside. When we put our ancestors inside, we also bring their weapons so that they can carry it with them to heaven." Senior Hong said.

Yuan nodded, and they began approaching the doors.

And just like the grand elders had said, when they arrived in front of the large doors, their bodies began shivering uncontrollably.

However, it was not the type of shivering one would get when they were cold— it was the type that only occurs when one is fearful of something.

"I don't like this feeling one bit." Chu Liuxiang said as she looked at her own hands that were trembling uncontrollably.

"Young Lady, I think we should stay out here. If anything happens to you..." Sebastian said to her with a profound frown on his face.

"If Brother Yuan is going inside, I will be doing the same," she quickly said.

"How come you are fine, Yuan?" Meixiu noticed that Yuan was the only person there that wasn't shivering.

"Eh? I don't know. I don't really feel anything," he shrugged.

"In fact, my body feels a little warmer than usual."

"Warm?" Everyone there raised their eyebrows.

A moment later, all six grand elders retrieved a golden key before inserting them inside the six keyholes in the center of the door.

"One, two, three."

At the count of three, they turned the keys simultaneously, unlocking the doors that hasn't been opened for at least a hundred years.

Upon opening the doors, they were immediately greeted by a hallway with the only light source being the dimmed lights on the walls.

"Let's go." Senior Wang said to them after retrieving the key.

Yuan and the others proceeded to follow the grand elders inside the tomb.

Once inside the tomb, their bodies would miraculously stop shivering.

However, it was the complete opposite for Yuan, whose body would gradually become warmer the deeper they entered the tomb, almost as if his body was reacting to something within the tomb.

After walking for a few minutes, they would arrive in this massive room at the end of the hallway.

Inside this room that was as large as two football fields, there were hundreds of coffins and display cases with weapons neatly arranged.

'Wow...' Yuan and the others were immediately in awe after seeing the place that looked like a historic site more than anything.

"Do you guys see anything out of the ordinary? I don't." Senior Wang asked the other grand elders after looking around.

"Nope. I don't see anything different, either."

"Everything looks normal to me."

They all expressed the same thoughts.

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Chapter 586 - Hidden Staircase

"Brother Yuan, how is your body feeling? Is it still heating up?" Chu Liuxiang asked him.

He nodded and said, "Yes, it's still heating up, but it doesn't hurt, so it's nothing to be worried about."

"If you ask me, I think your body is reacting to something within this tomb. Maybe you actually belong to one of the Six Spiritual Families, and your body is telling you so." Chu Liuxiang chuckled as she joked.

"I belong to one of the Six Spiritual Families?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

As ridiculous as that sounded, it wasn't completely impossible. As an orphan, his real background could be anything, and that includes one of the Six Spiritual Families.

However, they won't really know for certain until there is solid proof.

"Anyways, jokes aside, look at these weapons. Many of them are treasures." Chu Liuxiang said as she approached the weapon display cases.

"They give off the same aura as Spirit-grade weapons in Cultivation Online..." Yuan mumbled.

While Yuan and the others looked at the weapons, the grand elders scattered around the tomb to make sure there wasn't anything out of the ordinary.

About half an hour later, they all gathered again.

"Anything?"

"Nope."

"Nothing."

Yuan then asked, "Is this the only room in the tomb?"

"Yes. Although we don't have the layouts of this tomb, this is the only room that we know of. However, we do have speculations of a hidden room somewhere in this tomb. We just don't know where it is." Senior Wang said.

Senior Hong then spoke, "We believe there is a hidden room somewhere mostly because our founders' coffins cannot be found in this main room. They are probably in a hidden room, but we cannot find it no matter where to looked. Besides the entrance that is also an exit, there are no other paths in this tomb, and we don't dare to tear apart the tomb to find this hidden room without concrete evidence that it exists."

Yuan pondered for a moment. If what Chu Lixuaing said is true— that his body is reacting to something inside this tomb, maybe he can find it by following his body temperature.

"Do you mind if I look around for a bit?" Yuan then asked them.

"Go ahead. We'll also look around again just in case we missed anything."

Thus, Yuan and the others began walking around the room.

"The longer we stay here, the creepier it gets..." Meixiu sighed.

"Are you not good with these kinds of things?" Yuan asked her.

"So you're afraid of ghosts and zombies?" Chu Liuxiang chuckled.

"It's not that I am afraid of these things, but the eeriness of this place makes me uncomfortable," Meixiu said.

"Don't worry, we'll probably leave right after looking around."

As Yuan walked around, he would feel his body temperature rising and lowering, almost like he was playing the game hot and cold.

Eventually, Yuan found the direction that would make his body temperature increase the more he walked in that direction.

"I think this is the spot. My body is burning right now." Yuan said.

Chu Liuxiang pressed the back of her cold hands on Yuan's forehead and immediately exclaimed, "Whoa! Your body is actually burning! Are you sure that you're not in pain?"

"Yes, I am perfectly fine."

Yuan then gathered the grand elders and explained to them the situation.

"For some reason, my body feels the hottest when I stand in this spot."

"This spot?"

The grand elders looked around and realized that they were in the center of the room.

However, they don't see anything out of the ordinary.

It was at this moment Chu Liuxiang suddenly squatted down and extended her hand towards the floor.

"Hey, there's air flowing from the floor..."

"What? Let me see." Senior Wang knelt on the floor and extended her hand, and sure enough, there was air blowing from the tile cracks.

Upon realizing the situation, she immediately began removing the floor tile while trying her best not to damage anything.

A few moments later, the large floor tile was removed, and to everyone's surprise, there was a staircase that led underground!

"Heavens... To think there was a hidden staircase in this place." Senior Wang mumbled as she stared at the hole with a dazed face, wondering to herself how they didn't find this until today.

"Are we going down?" Yuan asked.

"Of course." Senior Hong nodded.

Thus, they began walking this narrow and dark staircase, slowly descending deeper into the ground.

However, the chill that had disappeared when they entered the tomb suddenly returned for everyone beside Yuan, and it was much worse than before.

"Looks like whatever is down there is the cause of this chill." Senior Wang mumbled in a low voice as they descended deeper and deeper.

Half an hour later.

"Good lord, how far down does this staircase go? We've been walking nonstop for half an hour!" Senior Shi said, feeling more and more impatient.

And just as he finished his sentence, the others noticed a thin line of light a little further down.

They immediately quickened their steps, and a few minutes later, they arrived before this metal door.

After opening this door, they entered this small but eerie chamber that had six golden coffins arranged in a circle with what appeared to be a stone statue in the middle.

"This is it... This must be our founders' hidden tomb!" Senior Wang began shaking even more after realizing the situation.

The grand elders began approaching the coffins and the stone statue to take a closer look, but they halted their movements when Yuan suddenly shouted

in a panicked voice, "STOP! DON'T GET CLOSE TO THAT THING!"

Everybody there turned to look at him with surprised expressions, and Senior Wang asked, "What is going on?"

However, Yuan didn't say anything and continued to stare at the stone statue in the middle of the room with a deep frown on his face.

'Impossible! What is that doing here?!' Yuan cried inwardly when he recognized the stone statue that had a human figure, but if one looked closely, it had horns on its head and parts on its body that humans shouldn't have, resembling something Yuan had encountered inside Cultivation Online— a demon!

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Chapter 587 - Demon Statue

'I-It's a demon! Impossible! Why is there a demon in this place?!' Yuan was shocked to the core when he saw the demon statue.

Although he has only seen a couple of them, their unique features were more than enough for Yuan to immediately recognize them at glance.

'Wait! Calm down! I am overthinking things! There is no way demons really exist in this world, right? That is only a stone statue— nothing more!'

Yuan began trying to convince himself that the stone statue was merely just that and not a real demon that had been sealed even though it looked ridiculously realistic.

However, that didn't explain why his body was burning when looking at the demon statue, as his body was clearly reacting to it.

"Brother Yuan, what do you see?" Chu Liuxiang asked him when he remained silent for too long.

"S-Sorry, but I think I overreacted to that statue over there." Yuan pointed at the demon statue that was surrounded by the six golden coffins.

"The stone statue?" Everybody there turned to look at the statue.

Since it was sort of dark there, they didn't notice the horns and other features immediately.

When they eventually noticed these unique features, their eyes widened with shock.

"What the... Why is there such a thing in the founders' tomb?"

"What even is this thing? It looks like a human, but humans don't have horns."

"It's a demon, I think," Yuan answered their questions.

"A demon? How do you know this?" Chu Liuxiang asked him.

"Because I have fought with them before inside Cultivation Online..." Yuan sighed.

"Cultivation Online?" Everyone there turned to look at him with raised eyebrows.

Yuan nodded and proceeded to explain to them his encounter with demons inside the Mystic Realm.

"Demons are powerful and immortal beings that have existed since ancient times in Cultivation Online. They cannot be killed through normal means. You can crush their body, burn them, and even sever their head, but they will regenerate completely like it never happened."

"I have fought a couple of them inside the Mystic Realm, and I was nearly killed by them."

"Wait... If they can regenerate any injuries no matter how severe, how do you defeat them?" Senior Wang asked.

"There are two ways to defeat a demon. You can destroy their body to the point where they cannot regenerate anymore, but they can fully regenerate within seconds even if they only have a single finger left, so that's not the preferred method."

"The second method is to seal them using a demon sealing technique, but that doesn't really kill them, and they will break out of that seal after a few hundred or thousand years depending on the strength of the seal."

"Oh, and I believe they're weak to techniques with the divine attribute."

"Heavens... How can such powerful entities exist? If they exist in our world in its current state, I highly doubt we will be able to defeat them." Senior Shi mumbled in a dumbfounded voice.

"Well, lucky for us, this is only a statue." Senior Xi said.

"What if it's not a statue?" Meixiu suddenly said.

And she continued, "What if that statue is the source of the calamity? If cultivation exists, then demons might also exist."

She turned to look at Yuan and said, "You've sealed them before, right? Can you look at that statue just in case? I have a bad feeling about it when I look at it."

Yuan nodded and used his divine sense to take a closer look at the demon statue without actually getting close to it.

"This is..." Yuan quickly frowned, but because of the mask blocking his face, the other couldn't see his expression.

If one looked at the demon statue with their bare eyes, they wouldn't notice anything out of the ordinary about it, but Yuan's divine sense allowed him to see things with more clarity, and he could immediately tell that the demon statue was not made out of stone.

Furthermore, he could sense a familiar feeling coming from within the statue—a feeling of carnage and bloodthirst.

"I... I think it's a real demon that had been sealed..." Yuan muttered in a voice of disbelief after a long moment of silence.

Nobody there responded for a very long time, as they were as baffled as Yuan.

"R-Real...? Are you sure?" Senior Wang asked for confirmation.

Yuan nodded and said, "I have sealed a few demons in Cultivation Online, and they all turn into that appearance when sealed. Furthermore... I can

sense unusual energy flowing through that statue."

"Good lord..."

"H-How long did you say demons can be sealed for?" Senior Hong asked him.

"I don't know. It all depends on the person who sealed the demon." Yuan shook his head.

Chu Liuxiang then spoke with a serious expression on her face, "This tomb has been here since ancient times, right? If you ask me, considering the situation with the calamity and the chilling energy from this place, there's a good chance that this demon is the calamity that we must face, and it's going to break out of the seal very soon."

"If that's the case, then we're all doomed! We have no way to defeat this demon if it really cannot be killed normally!"

The grand elders began panicking.

They suddenly looked at Yuan and said, "Y-You have experience with sealing demons, right?! Can you somehow reseal this demon before it breaks the seal?!"

"I'm sorry, but I don't really know how sealing demons work. I have a technique that allows me to seal demons, but I can only use that technique in Cultivation Online. I can try to learn the technique in this world as well, but I can't say for certain that it will happen before the demon breaks out of its seal, nor can I guarantee that it will work on the demon."

Senior Wang then said, "Let's look around to see if there are any clues for now. I'm sure the founders placed this demon in this place for a reason. Hell, they might've even left behind the method to deal with the demon... We can figure out the other things later."

Chapter 588 - Flesh And Blood

Yuan and the other began looking around the room, but there really wasn't much there to look at besides the sealed demon and the six golden coffins.

After a few minutes of looking around, the grand elders gathered.

"Besides the founders' coffin, there isn't anything else for us to look at." Senior Hong said.

"But to disturb the founders' peace..."

"If we don't do it, that demon will kill everyone once it breaks out of the seal! I'm sure they'll understand."

"You got a point..."

The grand elders then bowed to the golden coffins.

"We deeply apologize for disturbing your peace, founders."

After apologizing to their founders, the grand elders went to their family's coffin.

Each of the coffins had one of the Six Spiritual Families' surnames engraved into it, so the grand elders knew which one belonged to their family.

Once they were prepared, they opened the coffin to take a look inside.

However, to their surprise, all of the coffins were empty.

There was nothing— not even signs of a body having ever existed inside these coffins, almost like it was empty since the beginning.

"Why are these coffins here if they're empty?" Senior Wang muttered out loud everyone's question.

"If our founders are not in here, where are their bodies?" Senior Hong asked afterward.

"Let's look around again to make sure that there aren't any hidden passages."

Thus, the grand elders began around round of inspection.

Meanwhile, Yuan continued to analyze the demon statue with his divine sense.

He was fairly certain that the demon statue was actually a sealed demon, but he wasn't 100 percent confident.

"Brother Yuan, if the demon breaks out of its seal now, what are the chances of you defeating it?" Chu Liuxiang asked him.

After a moment of silence, he spoke in a solemn tone, "None. I have no chance of defeating a demon in my current state."

And he added, "That's why I need to quickly learn the demon sealing technique."

"Are demons really that powerful besides their regenerative abilities?"

"Yes, they're incredibly powerful. They can turn their own blood into weapons, and their bodies are incredibly durable by themselves. However, that's not what I am most worried about."

"A single demon at the Spirit Warrior level can defeat an ordinary Spirit Master cultivator. If this sealed demon is above that level, which is very likely, I won't be able to defeat it even with the demon sealing technique."

"Wait... If even someone like you cannot defeat the demon, who else can do such a thing?" Meixiu asked.

Yuan is very likely the strongest cultivator in this world at the moment, and if someone like that cannot defeat the demon, what chances do the others have? Won't they just be sitting ducks waiting to be slaughtered by this demon?

"Well... Since demons exist... I hope there's a demon sealing clan somewhere out there in this world." Yuan sighed.

"Demon sealing clans?" Chu Liuxiang asked.

"Yes, they're clans that specialize in sealing demons. They also exist in Cultivation Online."

Sometime later, the grand elders returned to Yuan with dispirited looks on their faces.

"I'm sorry, but this place is empty."

"Daoist Yuan, do you have any idea when the demon might break the seal?" Senior Wang asked him.

"Unfortunately, I do not."

"Hopefully, it won't happen for a few more years. Hell, I will be happy even with a few months." Senior Shi sighed.

"Let's get out of here for now. We won't gain anything by staying in here."

However, as they prepared to leave the hidden room, the ground started shaking.

"Another earthquake? We're getting them more and more frequently."

"Let's hurry upstairs. It would be bad if this place collapses due to the earthquake." Senior Wang suggested to them.

Everyone there agreed and began making their way towards the exit.

However, for some reason, Yuan stopped walking when they reached the door.

"What's the matter, Brother Yuan?" Chu Liuxiang asked him.

Yuan didn't say anything and used his divine sense to look at the sealed demon after feeling this urge to do so.

"No way..." He muttered in a low voice.

"What did you just say?" Senior Wang turned around to ask him.

"T-The demon... It's cracking..." Yuan responded in a low voice.

"What?!"

Everybody there immediately turned to look at the sealed demon, and sure enough, there were visible cracks on its body.

Furthermore, these cracks were emitting a red glow that would pulsate like a beating heart.

"D-Don't tell me that it's already breaking the seal! We're not ready to fight that thing!"

Senior Wang and the others that had been shivering this entire time started trembling like they were at the brink of freezing to death.

Meanwhile, the earthquake grew stronger and stronger.

Crack.

Crack...

Crack!

The cracks on the sealed demon began spreading all over the rest of its body at a rapid rate— fast enough for Yuan and the others to follow with their eyes.

"Run!" Yuan suddenly shouted at them.

The next second, Senior Wang and the others began running back upstairs at full speed.

When they were halfway to the surface, the sealed demon that was completely covered in cracks started trembling.

BOOM!

An explosion occurred inside the hidden room the next moment.

When the smoke dissipated, a red-skinned figure could be seen standing in the middle of the room, silently looking at its own hands with a look of disbelief and excitement in its gaze.

Once the demon realized its situation, it immediately burst with laughter.

"HAHAHAHA! I AM FREE! I AM FINALLY FREE!" The demon laughed like a maniac.

After countless years of being sealed, it had finally managed to break free from its imprisonment.

The demon proceeded to spend the next few minutes digesting its current situation and pondering what it should do next.

Then its senses picked up a familiar smell— the smell of humans, and its mouth immediately began salivating, as it'd been starved for thousands of years.

Once the demon realized that there were humans nearby, like a starved beast, it stopped pondering and began chasing after this smell.

"This is exactly what I want! Flesh and blood— I want to feast!" The demon roared as it sped up the narrow staircase, quickly chasing after Yuan and the others.

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Chapter 589 - Staying Behind

"W-What was that sound just now?!"

"It sounded like an explosion!"

"Fuck! I really hope the demon didn't just break out of its seal!"

The grand elders panicked as they ran upstairs.

Meanwhile, Yuan tried his best to learn the Demon Sealing Strike even as they moved, as that was essentially his only chance of winning against a demon at his current strength.

Eventually, they reached the surface and returned to the main tomb.

"Seniors, I am going to borrow some of the weapons in here!" Yuan said to them, and without waiting for a response, he retrieved a greatsword that resembled the Empyrean Overlord in size from its display case along with a couple of daggers.

"Weapons? Don't tell me you're planning to fight the demon!" Senior Wang asked him.

Yuan nodded and said, "I can sense a powerful aura quickly approaching us from the staircase. The demon will be here at any minute. If I don't stay here to stop it, everyone will die. That's why I will stay here to stall the demon while you all evacuate the disciples."

"No!" Chu Liuxiang immediately refused.

Then she said, "If you're going to stay here, I will stay here with you!"

"You must not, Young Lady! It's my duty to guarantee your safety!" Sebastian exclaimed.

"I don't care! I am not going to leave Brother Yuan here to die!"

"Then I will stay here with the Young Master in your place!" Sebastian said.

"What can you do, Sebastian?! You may be strong, but you're only a Spirit Warrior!"

"Lulu, leave!" Yuan suddenly shouted at her.

"B-But..." Chu Liuxiang looked at him with teary eyes.

Yuan lifted his hands to wipe her tears, and he spoke in a calm voice, "Don't worry, even if I cannot defeat the demon, I won't die. I promise."

He then looked at Meixiu and continued, "You too, Feng... No, Meixiu. Leave this place with Lulu. If anything happens to either of you... I will never be able to forgive myself."

After a moment of silence, Meixiu nodded her head, but she didn't say anything, mostly because she'll reveal the fact that she was crying behind her mask if she spoke now.

"No! I am not leaving you, Brother Yuan! We have yet to start our family! If you die, I will die with you!" Chu Liuxiang was still reluctant to leave.

Yuan sighed in an apologetic voice, "I'm sorry, Lulu..."

He then used his movement technique to get close to Chu Liuxiang, before knocking her out cold by hitting her with the sword hilt.

After catching the unconscious Chu Liuxiang, he handed her to Meixiu, "I'm sorry for the inconvenience..."

Yuan suddenly turned to look at the staircase, as he could feel the demon's presence getting incredibly close.

"Leave! Now!" He shouted at them.

"Follow me!" Senior Wang then said to them.

Meixiu and the others immediately followed Senior Wang outside.

However, a few of the grand elders stayed behind with Yuan.

"Seniors..."

"Daoist Yuan, do not forget that you are currently a guest at our home. Our ancestors will curse us to death from the heavens if we leave you alone now." Senior Hong said to him with a smile on his face.

"Although we may not be able to defeat the demon, we are not Spirit Masters for nothing." Senior Li spoke next.

"I know I shouldn't be excited about our situation, but I cannot wait to see how this demon look." Senior Shi laughed.

"Thank you all," Yuan said to them.

And for the next minute, the three grand elders that decided to stay behind went to grab a weapon from beside their ancestors' coffin.

"This place is going to be destroyed today, huh?" The grand elders looked around before shaking their heads.

Although they would rather take the fight outside their ancestors' tomb, they knew that wasn't practical, as there would be nothing to block the demon from fleeing.

However, inside their ancestors' tomb that only had one entrance that is also an exit, they would be able to stall the demon with more ease.

"Hahahaha! Humans! I can smell humans!!!"

A burst of cold laughter suddenly resounded, causing Yuan and the others to tremble.

Boom!

The next moment, a figure flew out of the hole with the underground staircase before landing many meters away from the others.

"Heavens... That's a demon?"

"What a hideous appearance..."

The grand elders felt the strength in their legs disappear when they saw a demon for the first time.

Glowing red skin that resembled lava, two black horns on the top of its head, clear red eyes that looked like they had been dyed in blood, and most noticeable, the red crystal embedded in the middle of its chest.

"Oh, sh*t..." Yuan subconsciously cursed when he sensed the unfathomable aura coming from the demon, recognizing its strength that was at the peak of Spirit Master!

"That demon is a peak Spirit Master... Meaning it has the strength of a peak Spirit Grandmaster!" Yuan revealed this information to the grand elders.

Of course, their faces sank the moment they learned of this information.

"Strength of a Spirit Grandmaster?? How are we supposed to deal with that monster with just the four of us?! Even ten of us wouldn't be enough!" Senior Li exclaimed.

Meanwhile, the demon silently stared at them for a good moment before mumbling, "There's only four of them? I swear I smelled more than four people. Oh well, there should be plenty more humans outside this place..."

The demon suddenly began approaching Yuan and the others in a slow and calm manner, almost like it wasn't worried about them escaping from it.

"Humans, be obedient and offer yourself to me and I will make things as painless as possible. If you dare resist, I will make sure you feel it as I slowly tear your flesh from your body with nothing but my teeth." The

demon spoke with a hideous grin on its face, revealing its sharp yellow teeth to them.

In response to the demon's words, Yuan tightened his grip on the sword, and without waiting for the grand elders, he rushed at the demon.

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Chapter 590 - Let Me Eat You!

"HAHAHAHA!"

The demon started laughing when it saw Yuan running at it in a seemingly reckless manner.

"A mere early-stage Spirit Master dares to challenge me?! A demon?! Your mother must have never taught you about demons, human!"

The demon stood there without moving as it continued laughing even though Yuan was already in front of it.

"Ha!"

Yuan swung his sword with all of his might, tearing the demon's body in half.

"Oh? You're a little more powerful than you appear. No wonder why you dared to challenge me." The demon remained calm even after getting split in half.

"However, that won't be enough to stop me from ripping your flesh and chewing your bones."

The demon completely regenerated its body before it even finished its sentence.

"He wasn't exaggerating about their regeneration abilities... How are we supposed to defeat a monster like that?!"

The grand elders lost all will to fight when they witnessed firsthand the demon's heaven-defying regenerating abilities, and they could only stand

there in shock as they watched Yuan fight with the demon.

Of course, the demon wasn't taking Yuan seriously, as it was still filled with exhilaration from breaking free from the seal, so it wanted to play around with its food before eating them as a way of celebrating its freedom.

However, even as he was fighting the demon, Yuan didn't stop trying to comprehend the Demon Sealing Strike inside his head.

The demon eventually got tired of just taking Yuan's attacks and retaliated with its own attack.

"Bloody Claws!"

The demon used its blood to turn its fingers into a long and sharp weapon before swinging them at Yuan.

"Flying Daggers!"

Yuan controlled two separate daggers to attack the demon after backing up.

However, the demon completely ignored the daggers, allowing them to pierce its body as many times as it wants.

Of course, Yuan didn't care whether his attacks worked or not on the demon, as his only intention was to stall the demon for as long as possible so that Meixiu and the others could escape and evacuate the Jaded Garden.

Midway through his fight, Yuan suddenly began feeling the mysterious power once again, and his body emitted a golden aura.

"Hm?" The demon raised its eyebrows when it sensed this mysterious power within Yuan.

'What is that power? I want to taste it!'

The demon suddenly felt an uncontrollable urge to consume Yuan, and it no longer had the patience to play around with its food.

BOOM!

The demon released its cultivation base, creating a powerful shockwave that tossed the coffins in the room all the way to the wall.

"Let me eat you... LET ME EAT YOU!"

The demon drooled with saliva as it pounced at Yuan while emitting an incredibly bloodthirsty aura.

Yuan was surprised by the demon's sudden aggression, but he didn't panic, and the overwhelming power in his body helped calm his mind.

Clang!

Yuan took the demon's strike head-on with his sword, but even with his golden aura, he was pushed back by that strike.

Furthermore, while he was enveloped by this golden aura, his comprehension of the Demon Sealing Strike would progress a little faster.

Bang!

Clang!

Boom!

The entire room was destroyed as Yuan and the demon fought back and forth with broken coffins and dried-up corpses that had been resting inside these coffins scattered around like trash.

This was a heartbreaking scene for the grand elders, but they were too terrified of the demon to even do anything about it.

However, one cannot blame the grand elders for being scared out of their minds, as demons have this savage aura that makes humans instinctively fear them.

Meanwhile, Yuan was on the verge of being suppressed by the demon.

Even though he has his golden aura that significantly boosts his strength, it wasn't nearly enough to deal with the demon, who was actually growing more and more powerful as it got used to using its body after being sealed for so many years.

Bang!

The demon swung its sharp hands at Yuan, sending him flying across the room.

Boom!

Yuan fell onto the floor after hitting the wall.

"Damn it... Why am I so weak?" Yuan quickly got back up to his feet.

Unfortunately, by the time he stood back up, the demon was already in front of him.

Whoosh!

The demon suddenly extended its claw-like hands out, grabbing Yuan by the neck and lifting him into the air with ease.

"You're pretty powerful for someone at the first level Spirit Master. Unfortunately, you do not have what it takes to deal with demons. You also have a mysterious power inside you. I cannot wait to taste your blood and acquire this power for myself."

The demon opened its mouth and prepared to bite a chunk out of Yuan's body, but it suddenly felt something pierce its body.

The demon looked down to see a spear piercing its chest. It turned around to see Senior Hong standing behind it with a spear in his grasp.

However, his expression was still filled with terror.

"Don't worry, you will get your turn after I eat this brat."

The demon sneered and returned to focusing Yuan, completely ignoring Senior Hong and the spear in its body.

Yuan, who had been trying to break free from the demon's hold, accidentally removed his mask from all the struggling, revealing to everyone there his face for the first time.

The grand elders weren't in the mood to care about Yuan's identity right now, so they didn't care.

However, when the demon saw Yuan's face, its body immediately began trembling with intense fear, almost like an animal right before its prey.

"YOU! WHAT ARE YOU DOING HERE?!"

The demon suddenly roared in a terrified tone, immediately released its grip on Yuan's neck, and even jumped back, distancing itself from him.

"You must be here to seal me again! No! I will not let you seal me for a second time! I will kill as many humans as I can before you take me!"

Almost like it had gone crazy, the demon began running towards the exit with its tail tucked between its legs, completely ignoring the fact that it'd just dominated Yuan.

"Fuck! The demon is leaving the tomb! We have to stop it!"

The grand elders that had been rooted in their spot this entire time suddenly regained their ability to control their bodies, and they immediately chased after the demon.

"Daoist Yuan! Are you okay?!" Senior Hong helped him to his feet.

"I am! Let's also chase after the demon! Many people will die if that demon leaves this place!" Yuan quickly stood up and began chasing the demon, not even bothering to ponder why the demon suddenly let him go.

However, the demon was too fast for any of them to catch, leaving Yuan and the others in the dust.

"Sh*t! It's heading towards the Jaded Garden!"

"How long did we manage to stall the demon for?! Hopefully, it's enough to let the others evacuate!"

"Daoist Yuan, you can go ahead of us!"

Yuan nodded and immediately used his movement technique while pouring all of his spiritual energy into it, reaching a speed that he didn't know was possible before.

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Chapter 591 - Trail Of Blood

After leaving the ancestors' tomb, Senior Wang and the others rushed back to the Jaded Garden to warn all of the disciples about the demon.

Of course, the disciples were in disbelief at first, but they eventually snapped out of their daze and started making their way to the evacuation site, where a private airport and dozens of large airplanes had been prepared just in case they ever needed to do a mass evacuation.

"Leave everything behind! The demon is being stalled by Daoist Yuan and the grand elders! Don't let their efforts go to waste!" Senior Wang shouted at the disciples that were stumbling around in a panic.

"Miss Meixiu, we have a helicopter. Let's leave here in advance." Sebastian said to her, who was still carrying Chu Liuxiang even though he'd offered to carry Chu Liuxiang for her.

Meixiu nodded.

Although they will be leaving behind their luggage, they can always return for them in the future when the demon is no longer a threat.

Thus, Meixiu followed Sebastian to the helicopter.

Of course, she made sure to warn the people in the hotel and Jean, who brought them to the Jaded Garden.

"What? There's a monster? How is that possible?"

Jean doubted Meixiu's words at first, but then the hotel he was staying at received news from the Jaded Garden about the situation.

"I will be leaving this place with them, so you can return by yourself," Meixiu said to Jean before following Sebastian to their helicopter and leaving the Jaded Garden.

"What are we going to do now?" Meixiu asked Sebastian once they were in the air.

"We'll stay in the Yang City for now, and depending on the situation, we may or may not return to the Chu Family. If the demon is dealt with, we will return to the Jaded Garden, but if things get bad, we will return to the Chu Family," Sebastian said.

"What about you? If you have no place to go, you can follow us back to the Chu Family."

"But Yuan..." Meixiu immediately hesitated, as she didn't want to leave Yuan behind in the Jaded Garden.

Sebastian remained silent for a moment before speaking, "He'll be fine. I don't know him very well compared to you or the Young Lady, but I have a feeling that he'll be okay. Furthermore, he wishes for your safety, so I cannot allow you to go back there until the demon is no longer a threat."

Thus, Sebastian controlled the helicopter, flying it to Yang City.

Shortly after Meixiu and the others left the Jaded Garden, the demon would enter the Jaded Garden, and it immediately began destroying everything in its sight.

Unfortunately, not everyone had evacuated from the Jaded Garden, and when the demon spotted them, it would immediately sink its sharp teeth inside their body before ripping out their skin and meat.

"What the fuck is that thing?!"

"Run! It'll kill us all!"

"Aaaaaaah! Help me! It's eating me! Help!"

Chaos immediately ensued from the demon's rampage, and wherever the demon appeared, there would be carnage.

Yuan returned to the Jaded Garden about ten minutes after the demon, and by the time he arrived, the demon had already killed hundreds of people.

"Damn it! I was too late!"

Yuan could feel his heart beating uncomfortably loud when he saw the scene, and he couldn't help but blame himself for not being able to stall the demon long enough for them to escape.

However, he didn't have the time to blame himself, and he immediately began following the trail of blood left behind by the demon.

After following the trail for a few minutes, Yuan suddenly recognized the direction it was heading, and his face immediately sank.

"The demon is heading towards the immortal caves...? Oh no! Azure!"

Yuan quickened his steps and rushed towards the immortal caves without looking at the trail anymore, and he silently prayed that Azure had already evacuated from the Jaded Garden.

'Please be safe, Azure!' Yuan's heart burned with anxiety as he rushed to the immortal caves.

Meanwhile, a few minutes ahead of Yuan, the demon arrived at the immortal caves that have the most spiritual energy in the entire Jaded Garden.

"Hahaha! I must have gone crazy from starvation when I ran away from that human! Now that I have satisfied my hunger, I can finally think again! That human! Although he looked like that bastard who sealed me, there's no way such a weakling could be that person!" The demon laughed out loud as it bit on a severed arm, chewing on the meat and bones together without any problem.

"Once I find that bastard again, I will make sure to consume him properly for embarrassing me like that!"

After walking for a few more moments, the demon suddenly stopped in its track when it noticed a female human sitting on top of a larger boulder, who appeared to be in deep thoughts— so she didn't notice the demon's presence.

The demon licked its lips and approached this unsuspecting individual.

Once the demon was close enough, the woman snapped out of her daze and turned to face the demon.

"Yuan?" She subconsciously muttered in a low voice.

Then she noticed that this presence reeked of blood and bloodlust.

"Who are you?" She asked, still unaware that she was before a monster that'd killed hundreds of people already.

The demon realized that this human was blind, so she couldn't see its hideous appearance.

However, the demon couldn't care less whether she could see or not, and it calmly walked up to her with its claw-like hands raised into the air before swinging it directly at the woman's chest.

It was at this moment a familiar voice frantically resounded, "Azure!"

"Yuan?" A smile subconsciously appeared on Azure's face when she heard his voice.

Then she suddenly felt a burst of pain in her chest.

Still unaware of the situation, Azure subconsciously touched the part of her chest where the pain was coming from, and to her shock, there was nothing, as a gaping hole had appeared in her chest.

A moment later, she collapsed, falling from the boulder and landing on the ground, but her body didn't react to the fall.

When Yuan, who'd arrived at the scene just to witness the demon thrust its bloody claws into Azure's chest, he roared in a desperate voice, "NO! AZURE!!!"

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Chapter 592 - Intense Killing Intent

"Oh? What a pleasant surprise. Looks like I no longer have to waste time looking for you. I will make you pay for that embarrassment before." The demon licked its hand that was covered in Azure's blood when it noticed Yuan standing a few meters away from it.

"Hm? This blood is fucking delicious!" The demon was surprised when it tasted Azure's blood.

"She will make for a good dessert after I finish eating you, human!"

The demon laughed loudly.

However, there was no response from Yuan, who silently stood there in a daze, almost like he'd turned into a stone statue.

Two streams of tears began flowing down his face a moment later when he realized the situation.

"Azure..."

Yuan eventually snapped out of his shock, and when he did, he gritted his teeth so hard that his mouth began bleeding.

"AAAAAAAAAAHHH!"

Yuan released a beastly roar that shook the trees around them before rushing at the demon without any movement techniques.

He was simply rushing at the demon in a reckless manner.

In fact, he wasn't even thinking at all, as his mind was filled with anger and desperation.

Sha!

The demon slashed its claw-like hands at Yuan, and because of its recent feast, its power had grown much more than previously, sending Yuan flying many meters into the distance.

Cough!

Yuan coughed out a mouthful of blood afterward, but he immediately stood up before rushing at the demon once again.

The demon quickly noticed Yuan's sudden change in behavior, and it turned to look at Azure's body on the ground.

"Oh? Did you know her? Perhaps she was your lover? What a pity. If I had known that earlier, I would've kept her alive so that I could torture her before you." The demon sighed in a regretful manner.

When Yuan heard the demon's words, he felt something snap somewhere inside his body, and intense killing intent would gush from his body.

At this moment, Yuan could no longer think properly, but his body continued to function purely on instinct.

Yuan dropped the sword in his hand the next second.

When the demon saw this, it laughed, "Are you giving up already? Aren't you going to avenge your girlfriend? What a pathetic existence you are even for a lowly human."

However, the next moment, a beautiful sword would appear out of thin air before falling into Yuan's grasp, and this sword greatly resembled his Empyrean Overlord from Cultivation Online.

The second this sword appeared in this world, it released a divine aura that sucked all of the spiritual energy from the immortal caves almost instantly,

turning the place into an ordinary location.

"Where the hell did you pull that thing from?" The demon could sense an unfathomable power hidden within the sword, but it wasn't scared.

After all, no matter how powerful the sword was, its wielder was powerless.

Once the sword was in Yuan's grasp, he immediately rushed at the demon again.

Bang!

The demon used its claws to block the sword, but the massive sword was countless times heavier than it appeared, and it tore right through its claws before slashing the demon's body in half.

And before the demon could even have a chance to regenerate, it felt something pierce its face, creating a gaping hole in its head.

'Where did that attack come from? I didn't see anything...' The demon wondered to itself as its body quickly regenerated until all of its injuries were healed.

Yuan would continue his mindless assault on the demon, but no matter how many times he slashed the demon's body in half or tore a hole in its head, the demon would regenerate until there's not even a single scratch on its body.

"Are you done yet?" The demon casually patted its shoulders, clearly unaffected by Yuan's attacks.

"Then it's my turn."

The demon released its cultivation and started attacking Yuan aggressively, quickly overpowering Yuan.

"Even though you'd gained more strength, you're actually weaker than before. What a disappointment. Allow me to end your worthless life right now!"

The demon suddenly grew a tail made out of blood before using it as a weapon, and because of Yuan's mindless state, he was unable to defend against this sneak attack.

The demon's tail pierced the center of Yuan's chest the next second.

Cough!

Yuan coughed out another mouthful of blood, and because of the intense pain in his chest, he snapped out of his daze, but it was too late, as there was already a hole in his chest.

The demon swung its tail, sending Yuan flying across the place once again.

However, Yuan didn't stand back up this time and remained lying on the cold ground, as he'd completely lost his consciousness, falling deep asleep.

Inside his dream that started the moment he lost consciousness, Yuan stood before Azure's figure, who was sitting on the boulder with her back facing him.

"You broke your promise to protect me, Yuan," Azure spoke to him in a gentle voice.

"I'm sorry... I'm really sorry..." Yuan could only mutter these few words as tears flowed from his eyes.

"Haaa..." Azure merely sighed in response.

"If only I was stronger... If only I gave you a proper answer... If only—!" Yuan kneeled on the ground as he contemplated what he could've done to prevent this situation.

After a moment of silence, a voice resounded, but it didn't belong to Azure.

"Losing to such a weak demon... Truly pathetic..."

Yuan lifted his head to look at the handsome man standing behind him, but there was something different about this handsome man and his aura, and

he was wearing a black and golden robe that had the words 'Bane of Demons' on it.

"Go ahead. Laugh at me for being weak like you always do. I deserve it." Yuan said.

However, the handsome man didn't laugh, nor did he say anything, merely staring at Yuan with a solemn face.

After a long moment of silence, the handsome man lifted his hand and pointed it in front of Yuan.

"Stand up and fight it," he spoke in a calm voice.

Yuan turned his head to see the demon standing not far away from him, and it was approaching Azure, who was still sitting on the boulder.

Seeing this, Yuan shook his head, "What's the point? I won't defeat it no matter what."

"I said stand up!"

The handsome man suddenly roared, and Yuan could feel an invisible force pulling him to his feet.

Once Yuan was standing, the handsome man suddenly took a step forward, walking straight into Yuan.

Yuan expected the handsome man to bump into him, but to his surprise, almost as though his body was made out of air, the handsome man walked through his body before disappearing from his sight.

The next moment, Yuan could feel his body moving, but he was not the one controlling it, and he began approaching the demon in the distance.

Meanwhile, in the real world, as the demon approached Yuan's unconscious body, it suddenly stopped moving when it noticed Yuan's body twitching.

"Not dead yet?" The demon sneered before aiming its tail at Yuan's head.

However, right before the tail reached his head, Yuan's hand suddenly moved to grab the demon's tail, stopping it an inch away from his head.

The demon didn't think anything of his movements at first, but then its body began trembling for some reason.

The next moment, it noticed that its tail was beginning to feel stiff, almost as though it was turning solid.

The demon's eyes widened with terror when it felt this familiar feeling, and it subconsciously cut off its tail before jumping backward.

"You fucking bastard..." The demon muttered in a low voice as it watched the tail that it'd severed turn into stone a second later.

"You can use demon sealing techniques?! Who are you?!" The demon roared at Yuan, who was slowly getting back to his feet.

Once he was standing, Yuan casually patted his clothes before speaking in a calm voice, "You don't recognize me? And you call yourself a demon?"

Yuan lifted his head to face the demon with a slight grin on his face.

"I cannot remember the last time I snacked on a demon core, nor do I recall their taste. Perhaps you can help me remember, lowly demon..." Yuan then licked his lips like a starved man craving food.

Chapter 593 - Demon Sealing Zone

"S-Snack on demon cores...? I-Impossible... You can't be...!" The demon quickly realized Yuan's identity, but it didn't dare to actually believe it.

After all, there is only one person in this universe who can consume demon cores, and that individual is the founder of the Demon Sealing Clan, Divine Paragon!

The Divine Paragon is the bane of all demons. No matter how powerful a demon is, they will remain as mere ants before the Divine Paragon, who can kill demons as simple as breathing.

"Y-You cannot be the Divine Paragon! What are you doing here?! Why do you look like that?! Why are you showing your true identity now?!" The demon questioned him.

"Whether I am real or not... Why don't we put that to the test?" Yuan spoke in a calm voice as he slowly approached the demon.

Furthermore, Yuan had activated the golden aura once again, but it was much clearer than previously, and he had complete control over it.

The demon took a step back every time Yuan took a step forward, but it didn't dare to turn around and run, as it was afraid that if it turned its back to Yuan, it would die without realizing what had happened.

However, after walking a dozen steps, the demon suddenly felt something against its back, preventing it from walking back any further.

The demon subconsciously turned around to see what was blocking it, as it was certain that there wasn't anything in that direction, and sure enough, when it looked, there was plenty of empty space behind it.

However, for some reason, it was unable to move any further, almost like there was an invisible wall there.

"Where do you think you're going?" Yuan suddenly spoke to it.

The demon immediately turned to look at Yuan, who had a malicious grin on his face.

"You can force your way outside this formation if you'd like, but just know that the moment you leave this field, you will become sealed. This technique is called the Demon Sealing Zone. Once activated, any demons within the zone will no longer be able to leave. If you do... you'll become sealed."

"D-Demon Sealing Zone?! Y-You really are...!"

The Demon Sealing Zone is one of the Divine Paragon's many unique techniques that allow him to completely turn any demon into powerless mortals, and it is also why all demons fear him.

Once they enter this zone, they will no longer be able to leave for the rest of their lives, and if they force their way out of this imprisonment, they will only be greeted with another form of imprisonment that is getting sealed.

"Since you're just a lowly demon, I will give you a chance to escape." Yuan suddenly said.

"R-Really?!" The demon's eyes flickered with hope.

However, when it heard what Yuan said next, its face sank.

"If you can defeat me, I will let you walk out here without getting sealed."

"Fuck you! You might as well keep me in here forever!" The demon cursed.

Yuan shrugged and said, "Since you'll stay in this place forever, you might as well try and defeat me."

The demon gritted its sharp teeth, but it found no fault in Yuan's words. Indeed, if it doesn't try to defeat him, it will never be able to escape the Demon Sealing Zone that has tormented countless demons before.

The demon prepared to launch its attack on Yuan.

However, right as it was about to strike, Yuan snapped his fingers, forcing the demon onto its knees with a tyrannical pressure that came out of nowhere.

"W-What is the meaning of this?!" The demon shouted out loud.

"You actually think you have a chance to defeat me? A lowly demon such as yourself? Know your place."

The tyrannical pressure suddenly became countless times more powerful, immediately flattening the demon into meat paste the next second.

Of course, the demon regenerated a few seconds later.

The demon tried to lift its head to look at Yuan after recovering, but before it could even lift its head halfway, the pressure flattened its body once again.

Once the demon regenerated, Yuan flattened it for the third time.

Then a fourth time.

A fifth time.

A dozen times.

"Why are you wasting your energy on such pointless attacks? Such attacks have no use on me, as demons don't feel any pain!" The demon managed to speak after regenerating for the 13th time.

"I am merely playing with you. Don't worry, the real punishment starts now."

Yuan snapped his fingers, creating a golden sword made purely out of spiritual energy, before sending it flying at the demon's hand, pinning it to the ground.

"AAAAAH!"

The demon suddenly screamed in pain.

When the demon realized what had just happened, it looked at Yuan with a terrified face.

"What did you do to me?!" The demon roared.

"This must be your first time experiencing real pain, huh? The fact that demons cannot experience pain... is false. Demons also experience pain, but their tolerance to pain is quite admirable— to the point where they don't feel any pain even when their body is turned to meat paste."

"All I did was simply remove your pain tolerance, allowing you to experience pain as normal humans would. Don't worry, you won't die even if you can feel pain, but you will definitely wish for death after I am done with you."

The demon began to sweat for the first time in its life when it saw the sadistic smile on Yuan's face.

However, right as it opened its mouth to speak, the pressure flattened its body once again.

This time, the demon felt every ounce of pain that came from having its entire body crushed into meat paste.

Once it regenerated, the demon shrieked like a pig being slowly slaughtered; it was a ghastly sound that would make even the toughest men on earth tremble in fear if heard.

"Hey, how many humans did you kill today?" Yuan suddenly asked it.

And he continued, "I will crush you ten times for every human you killed. If you don't tell me, I will torture you until I feel like stopping."

The demon stared at Yuan with a terrified gaze.

"You... monster!" It muttered in a powerless voice.

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Chapter 594 - A Demons Cry

Chapter 594 - A Demon's Cry

"Hurry up and tell me how many humans you killed today. I'm not a very patient person." Yuan spoke before crushing the demon into meat paste again.

Once it regenerated, the demon muttered in a trembling voice, "I-I don't remember..."

"You don't remember? Maybe this will jog your memories."

Splat!

The demon slammed into the ground, instantly turning into a pool of blood.

"Do you remember now?" Yuan asked it again after it regenerated.

"I—"

However, before it could even speak, Yuan interrupted it by flattening it again.

"AAAHHHH!"

Splat!

"AAAAAAAHHHH!"

Splat!

After flattening the demon a dozen times, Yuan finally stopped flattening it without letting it speak.

"Do you remember now?"

"I-I-I remember! I remember! Please! I remember everything!" The demon quickly responded this time, as it feared that Yuan would flatten it again before it could even speak.

"Speak."

"I-I killed—"

Splat!

The demon was flattened again before it could even give an answer.

Once the demon regenerated, Yuan said in a calm voice, "Oh, my bad. I instinctively flattened you just now."

The demon felt like cursing out loud, but it resisted and spoke, "138 humans! I killed 138 humans today!"

"138 humans, huh? Then I will have to flatten you 13,800 times as punishment." Yuan casually said.

"What?! 13,800?! You said ten times for every human I killed! It should be 1,380 times!" The demon quickly said in a panicked manner.

"Hm? You can do math? How surprising. Either way, I don't have the time to torture you so many times, so I will torture you with a different method."

Yuan snapped his fingers, creating three more golden swords before sending them at the demon's other hand and legs, completely pinning the demon on the ground.

Yuan then summoned one more sword, and this golden sword was twice the size of the other swords.

Once he created the sword, he sent it flying into the demon's back.

"AAAAHHHH!"

The demon roared, feeling indescribable pain that was many times more painful than being flattened into meat paste.

Once all five golden swords were piercing the demon's body, Yuan casually waved his hands.

The next moment—

"AAAAAAAAAAHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHH!"

The demon released its loudest scream yet when a thousand tiny golden swords suddenly burst from within its body, turning the demon's body into something that looked like it had been attacked by a porcupine.

Its eyes, mouth, ears— there were tiny golden swords all over its body.

The pain was so unbearable that the demon lost consciousness.

Unfortunately, the demon's regenerative abilities would kick in a moment later, taking away its peace that lasted only a short moment.

"Please... Stop..."

The demon pleaded with bloody tears flowing down its face.

"Hm? What did you just say? I couldn't hear you, so I will assume that you want to experience it again."

And without waiting for the demon to respond, Yuan created another burst of golden swords inside its body.

"AAAAAAAAAAHHHHHHHHHH!"

The demon's cry echoed in the Jaded Garden that was almost completely evacuated by now.

Meanwhile, Senior Hong and the other two grand elders that stayed behind with Yuan had finally managed to return to the Jaded Garden.

They were shocked to see the destruction caused by the demon, but before they had any chance to ponder about the situation, they heard an inhuman scream coming from the direction of the immortal caves.

The grand elders mistook this inhuman cry as a human crying for help, so they immediately rushed to the scene.

And to their absolute shock, when they arrived at the scene, they could only see Yuan standing in front of a collapsed demon that had many golden swords piercing its body.

The grand elders doubted their eyes for a moment, but they eventually came to the realization that it was actually the demon who was crying for help when they heard the inhuman screams!

However, they didn't dare to approach the scene at this moment, as they felt that something was different— odd about Yuan, so they decided to watch them from a distance.

"Hey, what did you say just now? Can you repeat it for me?" Yuan asked the demon afterward.

"Please... Stop..." The demon pleaded again.

After a moment of silence, Yuan spoke in a cold voice, "I refuse."

And another burst of golden swords assaulted the demon.

However, Yuan didn't stop this time and continued to create golden swords inside the demon's body.

Eventually, the demon's figure was entirely covered in golden swords, making its appearance unrecognizable.

Sometime later, Yuan removed all of the golden swords from the demon's body.

Although the demon was on the verge of going insane, it recognized its chance to escape from this hell, and the moment it could move again, it

immediately stood up and began running away.

Yuan could've easily prevented the demon from running, but he didn't do anything and silently watched the demon run.

The demon quickly reached the invisible wall, but it didn't care and continued to move forward, slowly forcing itself out of the Demon Sealing Zone.

"I'd rather be sealed again than let you play with me any further, Divine Paragon!" The demon laughed out loud as it exited the Demon Sealing Zone, feeling relieved that it will all be over soon.

The moment the demon left the formation, its entire body turned into stone, becoming sealed again.

"Yes! He did it! He really defeated the demon!" The grand elders were excited to see the demon sealed again.

Seeing the demon sealing itself, Yuan burst out laughing, and he calmly approached the sealed demon.

Once he was in range, Yuan gently tapped the sealed demon with his finger.

A moment later, cracks began appearing on the sealed demon, shocking the grand elders.

"W-What...?"

The demon, who had lost consciousness after being sealed, was suddenly awake again.

It silently stood there in a daze, wondering to itself if it was dreaming.

Seeing the demon's puzzlement, Yuan spoke with a grin on his face, "Did you really think you could escape my punishment by sealing yourself? If I can seal you... I can also unseal you!"

When the demon heard Yuan's words and realized that it wasn't dreaming, it literally lost its mind from shock and terror, and it also finally understood why even the strongest demons would run away in fear when they hear the name 'Divine Paragon'.

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Chapter 595 - Last Breath

"Once a demon opposes me, whether they die or live, is no longer within their control..." Yuan stood before the demon with an overbearing atmosphere around him, looking like an overlord.

The demon, which had lost its sanity, suddenly released a long and beastly roar.

Its glowing red eyes turned dark red, and vigorous veins began popping all over its body.

The demon also grew in size, becoming about 30 percent larger.

Yuan smiled when he saw this, and he muttered in a low voice, "Looks like it's about time I stop playing with my food."

"DIIIIIIEEEEEEEEEEEEEE!!!"

The demon swung its claw-like hands at Yuan with all of its power.

Seeing this, Yuan casually blocked the attack with his bare arms, completely stopping the demon in its tracks despite being an entire realm weaker than it.

After blocking the attack, Yuan suddenly extended his free arm, aiming it at the red crystal in the demon's chest.

Sha!

Yuan's hand pierced the demon's body like how it pierced Azure, before pulling out the red crystal from its chest.

Normally, even if the red crystal is removed from a demon's chest, it would simply turn into blood and return to the demon, but in this case, the red crystal didn't turn into blood and remained as a crystal inside Yuan's grasp.

"Disappear from my sight, you lowly demon."

Yuan then tightened his fist, crushing the red crystal into countless tiny fragments.

The demon suddenly stopped all movements.

A moment later, the demon's body began melting like ice cream under the blazing sun until nothing but its demon core was left.

Once the demon core was revealed, Yuan casually picked it up before putting it inside his mouth without any hesitation, shocking the grand elders.

The demon core immediately melted inside his mouth.

'As expected of a lowly demon, its demon core taste like trash even though it was terrified out of its mind. Looks like no matter how much I scare a lowly demon, it will not enhance the taste by much.' Yuan thought to himself.

Perhaps he was the only one in the universe who had such knowledge—that a demon's core will taste better if the demon was terrified before its death, hence why the Divine Paragon would always play with the demons before killing them.

If the world learned that the Divine Paragon had been torturing demons just to make their demon core taste better inside his mouth, they would begin to question if he was actually the real demon all along.

After killing the demon and consuming its core, Yuan's cultivation base soared from the first level Spirit Master all the way to the peak level Spirit Master!

However, Yuan completely ignored his breakthroughs and turned his focus onto Azure, who was lifelessly lying on the ground.

He approached her before taking a knee beside her.

"I'm sorry, but I do not have the power to save you," he sighed.

Meanwhile, inside his consciousness, Yuan had witnessed the entire scene from beginning to end.

The handsome man wearing the black and golden robe appeared before him again and spoke, "The woman is not dead yet, but she does not have much time left. I will give you a chance to fulfill her dreams before she is no longer in this world." The handsome man said.

The handsome man that had been controlling Yuan's body this entire time began pouring some of his golden aura into Azure's body, sealing all of her pain and waking her up temporarily.

Once he was finished, he returned the control to Yuan.

"Azure!" Yuan called out to her.

"Yuan...? For some reason... I am feeling very tired... and cold..."

Azure slowly opened her eyelids, revealing to Yuan her beautiful blue eyes for the first time and the reason for her name.

"It's okay... You just need some rest..." Yuan said, trying his best to not cry.

"You're right... I haven't been able to sleep properly for the last few days... ever since I met you..." She mumbled in a low voice, still oblivious to her situation.

"Yuan... I'm sorry..."

"Why are you apologizing? I should be the one apologizing to you..."

"I'm sorry... for making things awkward between us so suddenly... If only I was a little more patient..."

"No, don't be sorry... I was happy when you told me..."

"Really? Does this mean you'll accept me as your girlfriend?" Azure asked with a gentle smile on her face.

"Yes... I will accept you as my girlfriend..."

"Thank the heavens... I was really worried... that you would reject me..."

After a moment of silence, Azure spoke, the strength in her voice becoming weaker, "Hey... Yuan... Can you do me a favor before I fall asleep?"

"Of course. Whatever you want."

"Can you kiss me? This will make our relationship official..."

Yuan didn't hesitate and gently kissed Azure on her soft lips, but it was one that tasted like blood.

"I love you, Yuan..."

Azure took her last breath after that sentence before falling asleep with a blissful smile on her beautiful face.

After Azure left this world, Yuan also collapsed, as the toll on his body had finally caught up with him, sending him into a deep coma.

Seeing this, the grand elders finally decided to approach them.

"Are they still alive?" Senior Li asked.

Senior Hong went to check Yuan's pulses first and nodded, "He's still alive."

"As for Azure... I'm afraid she's no longer with us..." Senior Hong sighed after checking her pulses.

"What a tragedy..." Senior Shi shook his head.

"Let's hurry up and get Daoist Yuan out of here and to a hospital. He might be in critical condition." Senior Li then said.

"I will take care of Daoist Yuan. You guys take care of the rest." Senior Hong then picked up Yuan and quickly disappeared from the scene.

Meanwhile, Senior Shi and Senior Li contacted Senior Wang and the other grand elders, telling them that the demon had been dealt with and that they were safe to return to the Jaded Garden.

"What?! The demon has been defeated?! Are you sure about this?!" Senior Wang stood up from her seat as she exclaimed.

"Yes, we witnessed Yuan defeating the demon with our own eyes." Senior Li confirmed.

"We are coming back! Tell us everything once we return!"

Senior Wang then told the pilots to turn the airplane around, returning to the Jaded Garden.

Chapter 596 - Founder Of The Demon Sealing Clan

After arriving in Yang City, Meixiu and Sebastian rented out a hotel to stay in for the time being, as Chu Liuxiang was still unconscious.

"Brother Yuan!"

Chu Liuxiang woke up shouting about half an hour after they arrived at the hotel.

"W-Where are we?! Where's Brother Yuan?!" Chu Liuxiang asked Meixiu, who was in the same room.

"We are currently in Yang City," she replied.

"What about Brother Yuan?!"

"He's... still in the Jaded Garden..."

"Why?! Why did you leave him behind?! I thought you loved him!" Chu Liuxiang cried out loud.

"Calm down, Young Lady." Sebastian suddenly said.

"It was the Young Master's decision. If you truly love him, you would respect his wishes."

"T-That's..." Chu Liuxiang was immediately left speechless by Sebastian's words. Clearly, he was used to dealing with her.

"Believe in the Young Master. He's destined to achieve great things in the future, so he won't die there," Sebastian continued.

"I guess you're right... But what are we going to do now? I cannot just sit around and do nothing! Call my father! We're going to request his help to deal with the demon!" Chu Liuxiang then said.

"I have already notified the Masters of the situation. They are currently pondering on how they should approach this problem as we speak. We can only wait for their response now."

"This situation is much direr than you probably think, Young Lady. If the demon is allowed to run rampant, it could very well be the end of humanity."

"Haaa..." Chu Liuxiang sighed.

Sometime later, Meixiu suddenly received a call from Senior Wang.

"Feng! You need to return to the Jaded Garden! The demon has been defeated, but Daoist Yuan is currently in a critical condition!"

"What?!" Meixiu exclaimed in a shocked voice.

"I will be there as soon as possible!"

"What happened?" Chu Liuxiang asked her.

"It's Yuan! The demon's been defeated, but he's in a critical condition!" She quickly explained.

"What?! Brother Yuan is in a critical condition?! What happened to him?!" Chu Liuxiang completely ignored the part where Yuan defeated the demon and focused only on his condition.

"I don't know— we won't know until we return to the Jaded Garden."

"Sebastian!" Chu Liuxiang turned to look at him.

"R-Right away!" Sebastian had a delayed response since he was shocked to learn that Yuan had defeated the demon already.

Thus, they began making their way back to the Jaded Garden.

Meanwhile, inside the Six Spiritual Families' private hospital, Yuan was being taken care of by a dozen doctors at once.

They were preparing to do surgery on Yuan because of the massive injury in the center of his chest, but to their absolute shock, by the time they finished their preparations, the injury had closed on its own!

It was unlike anything they have ever seen before, and they questioned if Yuan was human or not afterward.

"Where am I? Am I dead?"

Yuan wondered to himself as he was surrounded by nothing but darkness somewhere deep within his consciousness.

"No, you're still alive." A voice suddenly responded to him.

Yuan turned around to see two figures standing behind him— both of them being the handsome man, but there were slight differences between them, such as their aura and demeanor.

One of them appeared to be the usual handsome man— the one who would appear in his dream the most often.

The second one appeared only recently, and he was the one who dealt with the demon.

"Why are there two of you? Are you the same person or two different people?" Yuan asked them.

The two of them looked at each other before smiling.

"Both." They responded simultaneously.

"We're both the same person but different people at the same time. You're also the same as us, yet you're a different person. Do you understand?"

"Reincarnation? But how can there be two of you?" Yuan then asked.

"Do you think a person can only reincarnate once? One can continue to reincarnate until their soul is broken or worn out, and with every reincarnation, one's soul becomes weaker, so not everyone is equal. Some people can only reincarnate once before their soul is worn out while others can reincarnate two... even three times." The Divine Paragon explained.

"How many times have I reincarnated by now? There's two of you right now, and that person who was wielding a spear is most likely one as well, so there's at least three." Yuan said.

"Who knows." They both shrugged.

Yuan then turned to look at the handsome man wearing the 'Bane of Demons' robe and said, "You're the Founder of the Demon Sealing Clan, right? But that only exists in Cultivation Online. Are you telling me that Cultivation Online is actually real— that it exists somewhere in this universe?"

"It's good to finally see you using your senses. Did that woman's death wake you up?" The other handsome man laughed.

Yuan gritted his teeth when the topic suddenly switched to Azure.

However, before he could say anything, the Founder of the Demon Sealing Clan spoke in a solemn voice, "It's not over just yet."

"What isn't over?"

"Both the demon and Azure," he responded.

"W-What do you mean by that?"

"You may have defeated one demon today, but do you really think that there is only a single demon in your world? You'll probably have to fight a few

more in the future when they eventually break from their seal."

"What?! There are more demons out there?!" Yuan exclaimed.

"Most likely, so you better prepare yourself before they break from their seal, or what happened to Azure will repeat again, and it could be either Meixiu or Chu Liuxiang who will take their last breath in your arms next," said the Divine Paragon.

"As for Azure... You might be able to see her again."

"Really?! How?!" Yuan no longer cared about the demons that might appear in the future and asked.

Divine Paragon then said, "Do you remember when I mentioned that a person can reincarnate as long as their soul is unharmed? If you find her soul..."

"Then I can reincarnate her?! Where can I find her soul?!"

Divine Paragon shook his head, "I cannot answer all of your questions now, but you might be able to find these answers, as well as your true origin, inside Cultivation Online."

"Cultivation Online..." Yuan mumbled.

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Chapter 597 - Aftermath

"Brother Yuan! Where's Brother Yuan?!" Chu Liuxiang rushed to the hospital after returning to the Jaded Garden with Meixiu and Sebastian.

"Daoist Yuan is currently resting in the patient room." Senior Wang said to them.

"What about his condition?" Meixiu then asked.

"Don't worry, he's no longer in a critical condition."

"Thank you..." Meixiu released a deep and relieved sigh.

"We don't deserve your gratitude, as we didn't really do anything. There was a massive hole in the center of Daoist Yuan's chest, but it closed up on its own before we could treat it."

"However, he's still in a coma, and we don't know when he'll wake up."

Senior Wang then led them to the room that Yuan was resting in.

Inside the room, the other grand elders as well as some of the elite disciples such as Wang Ming and Li Jinxi were there.

"Brother Yuan!"

Chu Liuxiang ran to the bed where Yuan was resting.

"What happened after we left?" Meixiu asked them.

"Take a seat. It's a long story." Senior Hong said.

Once they were seated, he began telling them about what had happened after they were separated.

"After all of you left, we stayed behind to stall the demon, but it was simply too strong, overpowering Daoist Yuan even though he was using his golden aura that allowed him to defeat Li Jinxi effortlessly."

"As shameful as this sounds, we didn't really do anything, as we were all frozen from shock. If you were there to witness the demon that looked like something from hell, you would understand..."

"Daoist Yuan slashed the demon in half more times than we can count, tearing holes in its face every few seconds, but no matter what kind of damage he did to the demon, it would regenerate completely within mere seconds."

"After fighting for some time, the demon suddenly ran away from the tomb for some reason, and we chased after it."

"Daoist Yuan was much faster than us, so he went ahead."

"By the time we returned to the Jaded Garden, the demon had already gone on a rampage, killing many disciples, and we are still figuring out how many people had fallen to the demon."

"Shortly after we arrived at the Jaded Garden, we heard this inhuman scream coming from the immortal caves. We thought it was someone crying for help, so we rushed there as soon as possible."

"However, to our shock, when we arrived, we could only see Daoist Yuan and the demon—with the demon being pinned on the ground by some glowing swords. We decided to remain distanced to watch the situation, and we quickly realized that it was the demon that had been screaming for help."

"We don't know what happened to Daoist Yuan, but he seemed like an entirely different person when he fought the demon for the second time,

completely overwhelming it without giving it any chance to fight back, even torturing and playing with the demon like it was some kind of toy."

"Yuan...?" Meixiu was shocked to hear that Yuan had tortured the demon, as that didn't sound like him at all.

"Also... Azure was one of the victims..." Senior Hong said to Senior Wang.

"Aiya! Azure! Why did I forget to warn her?" Senior Wang immediately slapped herself after hearing Azure's name, as she had completely forgotten about Azure, who would normally spend most of her time inside the immortal caves, not to mention how overwhelmed she was from the situation.

"So Junior Sister Azure is gone..." Wang Ming shook his head.

Azure was actually one of their most talented disciple who could comprehend many techniques with ease, but ever since she became blind, she would spend most of her time mastering the zither.

'Azure? That new friend Yuan made recently?' Meixiu thought to herself.

Although Yuan had mentioned that he made a new friend who can play the zither, they never really met Azure.

"Anyways, Daoist Yuan defeated the demon and ended the calamity shortly after." Senior Hong said.

"What should we do now?" Wang Ming asked.

"We first need to figure out the casualties so that we can notify their family, then we'll restore the areas destroyed by the demon. Once all of that is finished, we will figure the rest out." Senior Li said.

And for the next week, the Six Spiritual Families would work on restoring the Jaded Garden. As for Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang, they remained beside Yuan the whole time in the hospital.

Of course, news of what happened at the Jaded Garden had spread throughout the world, and the existence of demons was revealed to everyone.

News reporters flooded the Jaded Garden in hopes of getting interviews with the Six Spiritual Families, but they were all turned away.

Government from around the world also approached the Six Spiritual Families for questioning, and they were much harder to turn away for obvious reasons, so the Six Spiritual Families spoke with them.

And for Yuan's safety, the Six Spiritual Families didn't mention the person who defeated the demon, only saying that some powerful cultivator appeared out of thin air, defeating the demon in a blink before disappearing as quickly.

Of course, people knew that Yuan had fought with the demon, as Senior Wang had told everyone when they evacuated, but nobody besides very few people knew the whole story.

Yuan remained unconscious this entire time with nobody knowing when he'll wake up again.

While he was unconscious, Yuan would speak with the Divine Paragon and the handsome man whose identity was still unknown, and he would also regain some of his old memories.

Two weeks after the demon was defeated, Yuan finally woke up from his deep slumber.

"Brother Yuan! You're awake!" Chu Liuxiang was the first to notice his condition, as she would spend most of her time staring at his face.

Meixiu stopped her cultivation when she heard Chu Liuxiang's voice, and she quickly went to check on Yuan.

"Are you okay, Yuan? Can you speak?" Meixiu asked him.

Chapter 598 - The Calamity Is Not Over Yet

"I am fine... Where am I? And how long have I been asleep?" Yuan asked in a low voice.

"We are currently inside the Six Spiritual Families' private hospital, and you have been asleep for about two weeks now," Meixiu said.

"That long?" Yuan slowly sat up on the bed.

"I'm sorry if I made you two worried, but I am fine." He said to them a moment later.

"Wait right here. I will get the doctors to check your condition." Meixiu then went to call for a doctor.

After checking Yuan's body, the doctor said, "His body is a little weak right now, but besides that, everything is normal."

"Thank you, doctor."

"I need to speak with the grand elders," Yuan said to Meixiu.

"The calamity... It's not over yet."

"W-What...?" Meixiu's eyes widened with shock.

"What do you mean the calamity isn't over yet?! Didn't you defeat the demon already?" Chu Liuxiang quickly asked.

"Yes, the demon is gone. However, that isn't the only demon in this world. There are other sealed demons in this world, and they will eventually break from their seal."

"Unbelievable... So we'll have to deal with this again?" Meixiu muttered in a voice of disbelief.

Sometime later, the grand elders gathered at the hospital inside Yuan's room.

"Daoist Yuan! It's relieving to see you finally awake! I haven't had a wink of sleep for the last two weeks!" Senior Hong laughed when he saw Yuan awake.

"Senior Wang, did you bring the crystal?" Yuan asked her a moment later.

"Yes, but why do you need it?" Senior Wang retrieved the wooden box.

"Can you show me the crystal inside?"

Hearing Yuan's words, Senior Wang and the other grand elders could sense an ominous feeling in the air.

After taking a deep breath, Senior Wang opened the box, revealing the crystal inside.

"I-I-Impossible! Why is the crystal still yellow?! The calamity should have ended when the demon died!" Senior Hong exclaimed in a shocked voice.

"How do you know this, Daoist Yuan?" Senior Wang then asked.

Yuan took a moment to ponder an excuse before speaking, "The demon told me right before its death—that it wasn't alone in this world and that its comrades will eventually break out of its seal as well."

"Heavens..."

Senior Hong fell on his butt after hearing Yuan's words.

This means they will have to fight even more demons in the future, and if they are any stronger than the one they have already defeated, it will be a very grim moment for the world.

"Don't worry, I will take care of the demons." Yuan suddenly said.

And he continued in a cold voice, "I will personally eradicate every single demon in this world until there is none left!"

Everyone in the room swallowed nervously when they saw the cold expression on Yuan's face as he spoke those words.

Clearly, defeating demons has become something personal for him after Azure's death.

"Although we most likely won't be of any help to you when it comes to fighting demons, if you need anything, please let us know." Senior Li said to him.

"Yes, we owe you a great amount for defeating the demon. If it wasn't for you, our entire Jaded Garden would've been destroyed, and there would have been far more casualties." Senior Wang added.

She then handed the crystal to Yuan.

"This crystal can probably tell when a demon is about to break from its seal, so it will be more useful in your hands than ours. Please, take it."

Yuan nodded and accepted the crystal.

Sometime later, Senior Hong asked, "Daoist Yuan, what are you going to do now?"

"I am going home, then I will create my own faction," he responded.

"In order to create a faction, you will need more than three people. We can send you some of our own disciples to help you create your faction. If you want them to leave or even stay in your faction afterward, it's all up to you." Senior Wang said.

"Thank you." Yuan nodded.

Sometime later, Yuan and the others returned to the immortal caves to pick up whatever they left behind in a hurry.

"Senior Wang, do you mind if I take these two zithers with me?" Yuan asked her permission to take Azure's zithers.

"Go ahead." Senior Wang nodded.

And then she said, "If you wish to visit her grave before you leave..."

"Of course." Yuan nodded.

Senior Wang then brought him to where they buried all of the victims from the demon's rampage, and there was a total of 138 graves.

"This one is Azure's resting spot." Senior Wang showed him the way.

Yuan took a seat in front of her grave, and he placed Azure's zither on his lap.

He then started playing the zither, and it was one of the songs that he'd learned from Azure during their time together.

After playing the song, Yuan stood up and prayed, "If there's really a chance for us to play the zither again... I will make it happen... I promise..."

Sometime later, Yuan turned to Senior Wang and bowed to her, "Thank you for everything. I will ask for an alliance with the Spiritual Elites once I create my faction."

"Let us know before you create your faction so that we can send our disciples to you." Senior Wang nodded.

"Of course."

After saying his goodbyes with the other grand elders, Yuan left the Jaded Garden with Meixiu and the others, using Chu Liuxiang's helicopter to get

out of the place.

"We're going to return to our apartment first. What are you going to do now, Lulu?" Yuan asked her while they were in the air.

"I am going to follow you, of course. There is no way that I would leave before you create your faction," she said.

Once they arrived at Yang City, Yuan and Meixiu followed Chu Liuxiang to her private airplane, where they begin their journey back home.

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Chapter 599 - Returning Home

"Brother Yuan, you can be pretty cruel at times, you know?" Chu Liuxiang suddenly said to him after they lifted into the air in their private plane.

"Eh? Why would you say that?" Yuan asked in a dumbfounded voice.

"You already forgot about hitting me with a sword and knocking me unconscious?" Chu Liuxiang puffed her cheeks in an angry yet cute manner.

"O-Oh... That... I'm sorry, but if I didn't do that, you could've gotten hurt for real." Yuan apologized.

"I understand why you did it, and I am thankful that you did, but I cannot help but be upset about it. Therefore, as punishment, you'll have to hug me while we sleep tonight!" Chu Liuxiang then said.

Yuan didn't say anything and merely nodded with a slight smile on his face.

And for the rest of the flight, Yuan would remain relatively silent, seemingly in deep thoughts the whole time.

Neither Meixiu nor Chu Liuxiang tried to speak with him when they saw his mood, as they can tell that he was still in pain from what happened at the Jaded Garden, and sometimes, it was the better choice to let them ponder in peace than to try and comfort them.

After the whole incident in the Jaded Garden, Yuan's view of this world has flipped upside-down, and coupled with the new revelation that Cultivation Online exists somewhere in this universe, Yuan wasn't sure how he should do next.

The next day, when they had only two hours left before landing, Yuan gathered Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang for a conversation.

"Do either of you know how to actually create a faction or how to maintain it?" Yuan asked them.

"I have looked into it after you said that you wanted to create one, so I know the basics," Meixiu said.

"I don't think you have to worry about maintaining the faction if you do not plan on mass recruiting people. Even if there's a dozen of us in the end, we really don't have to do much, at least when compared to factions that have to deal with hundreds if not thousands of people." Chu Liuxiang said.

"Makes sense." Yuan nodded.

"Then can I trouble you two to help me create and maintain the faction? I will be very busy in Cultivation Online soon," he continued.

"Cultivation Online? Shouldn't you be preparing to fight the other demons when they eventually break out of their seal?" Chu Liuxiang looked at him with wide eyes.

How can one possibly think about playing a game when they still have the calamity to worry about?

Yuan remained silent for a moment before speaking, "This is going to sound crazy, but I believe that the world of Cultivation Online actually exists somewhere in this universe."

As he'd expected, both Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang looked at him with dumbfounded looks on their faces.

"How else do you explain why cultivation techniques from Cultivation Online work in this world? What about how eating treasures in Cultivation Online can affect our real bodies? I think that the device we use to play Cultivation Online somehow allows us to travel to the world of Cultivation Online."

"Wait... What do you mean eating treasures can affect our real body?" Chu Liuxiang asked, as she wasn't aware of this knowledge.

"If you eat a high-grade treasure in Cultivation Online, there's a chance that its effect could transfer to your real body. We have tested it, and it works." Meixiu explained, and she proceeded to tell Chu Liuxiang about that time she consumed a Berserker's Gem in Cultivation Online and how it affected her real body, giving her incredible strength.

"Unbelievable... To think that such things can happen... If that's the case, then Brother Yuan doesn't sound as crazy anymore. However, how does any of this work, really? How does the device allow us to travel to the world inside Cultivation Online? What about the NPCs there? They may act like real humans, but they never question the weird things that we do, such as respawning or disappearing and reappearing out of thin air."

"I cannot answer any of these questions right now, but I believe that we'll find the answers in Cultivation Online," Yuan said.

"As for the sealed demons that will appear in the future, I will be prepared for them when they break out of their seal. What happened at the Jaded Garden will not happen again."

And for the remainder of their flight, the three of them would talk about their new faction.

"Do you already have a name in mind for the faction?" Meixiu asked him.

Yuan nodded and said, "It will be called the Demon Sealing Faction. In the world of Cultivation Online, there is a power called the Demon Sealing Clan, and their sole purpose is to seal demons. I want to bring their purpose to this world."

And he continued, "Don't worry, I don't intend on letting you guys share the burden of sealing demons. I will do that alone."

"That's not right, Brother Yuan. If we're going to be in the same faction, we're going to be helping you! We may not have the powers to defeat

demons, but that doesn't mean we cannot help you defeat them!" Chu Liuxiang said.

Yuan pondered for a moment before nodding, "Alright. Then I will teach you guys some demon sealing techniques so that you won't be completely hopeless before a demon."

Two hours later, they landed the airplane and made their way back to the apartment.

"It feels like it's been forever since we left this place." Yuan sighed out loud as he sat on the couch.

"So this is your home, huh?" Chu Liuxiang began snooping around the place while Sebastian carried her luggage inside.

"Young Lady, the Masters said to call them when you get the chance. They want to make sure that you're okay." Sebastian said to her afterward.

"Hm? Okay." Chu Liuxiang nodded as she went inside Yuan's bedroom.

"This must be your room, Brother Yuan. It smells like you." Chu Liuxiang said with a smile on her face after taking a deep breath.

She then laid on the bed and continued, "This will also be my room starting today!"

Chapter 600 - Creating Their Own Faction

"Oh, right. Yuan, you should call Yu Rou. Although I'd already explained the situation to her, you should still speak with her." Meixiu said to him after unpacking their luggage.

"Okay."

Meixiu then handed her phone to him.

"Hello? Yu Rou? It's me, Yuan."

"Brother! Are you okay?!"

"Yes, I am fine."

"I'm sorry that I couldn't be there for you..."

"I would actually prefer it if you weren't here. I don't want you to be in such a dangerous situation." Yuan said.

After talking for a few minutes, Yu Rou asked, "What are you going to do now that you're back home?"

"I am going to create my own faction and focus on Cultivation Online."

"Eh? You're going to create your own faction? When?"

"As soon as we can, I guess."

"Why did you wait so long to make your faction, brother? If you'd told me earlier, I would've joined you! I am too invested in my faction to leave now..."

"Sorry..." Yuan had nothing else to say.

"Well... Make sure you visit me soon."

"I will when I get the chance."

After talking for a few more minutes, Yu Rou hung up the phone.

"Yuan, I have contacted Senior Wang. She said that she'll send a few people our way as soon as possible. We can create our faction as soon as they arrive." Meixiu said to him.

"Are you going to return to Cultivation Online now?" Meixiu then asked him.

"No, I will spend a few more days clearing my mind before I return," he said.

"Okay."

And for the remainder of the day, Yuan would cultivate in silence, trying his best to clear his mind. Of course, it was much easier said than done, as what happened at the Jaded Garden really affected his mind.

Once it was time to sleep, Chu Liuxiang eagerly jumped on Yuan's bed while wearing her see-through pajamas.

"We're going to be alone tonight, Brother Yuan." Chu Liuxiang giggled like a child.

"Yes, we are." He calmly said as he also entered the bed.

However, Chu Liuxiang didn't take advantage of their time alone, as she didn't want to advance their relationship while he was still feeling down.

'If I am going to start a family with him, it should be done when we're both happy and eager.' Chu Liuxiang thought to herself as she slept beside Yuan.

Meanwhile, on the other side of the room, Meixiu was having a hard time sleeping for obvious reasons, as she couldn't get her mind off the fact that Yuan was currently alone with a bold woman like Chu Liuxiang, who also has plenty of ambitions.

The following morning, Meixiu woke up early to cook breakfast, something she hasn't done in a while.

"Shall I help you out with breakfast?" Sebastian asked her.

"It's fine, you're the guest here," Meixiu said to him.

Sebastian nodded and returned to cultivating.

Shortly after Meixiu began cooking, Chu Liuxiang came outside of Yuan's room with a sleepy look on her face.

Meixiu turned to look at her with a questioning gaze.

Chu Liuxiang smiled and said, "Don't worry, I won't do anything for now, but once he's fully recovered, I will do it."

"You don't have to tell me that," Meixiu shook her head.

Once breakfast was ready, everyone sat around the table to eat.

"It's been a while since I tasted this flavor," Yuan said.

"Looks like you can cook a little, but compared to Sebastian, you're still lacking." Chu Liuxiang said, yet she kept eating without any breaks until she finished.

After breakfast, Yuan took a seat in his bedroom and began cultivating, but he had no intentions of trying to breakthrough to Spirit Grandmaster. Instead, he was doing it just to clear his mind.

Meanwhile, Chu Liuxiang would lay on the bed, silently watching Yuan cultivate.

"Don't you get tired doing that all day?" Meixiu asked her at the end of the day.

"Nope. I can watch him all day," she said.

Sometime in the afternoon the following day, Meixiu received a text from Senior Wang, stating that the disciples should be arriving at their apartment soon.

"They are here already? That was faster than I anticipated." Yuan said.

And sure enough, about ten minutes later, they can hear someone knocking on the door.

Meixiu went to open the door, and to her surprise, all of them were elite disciples from the Spiritual Elite, such as Wang Ming, Wang Bingbing, Shi Lang, Xi Murong, Hong Xiuquan, Wu Zao, and even Li Jinxi.

Basically, everyone that had participated in the Spirit Competition was there.

"Hey! We're here to help you create your faction! Of course, if you want us to leave afterward, we won't hold any hard feelings!" Wang Ming said to them with a wide smile on his face.

"Aren't you all elite disciples of the Spiritual Elites? Are the Six Spiritual Families really fine with sending away all of their most talented disciples to our faction?" Chu Liuxiang asked.

"Of course. Not only do we have our parents' approval, but even the grand elders urged us to join you guys." Shi Lang replied.

It was clear what the Six Spiritual Families' intentions were by sending all of their most talented disciples there.

If Yuan couldn't join them, they will simply join him instead! Furthermore, once they form an alliance with each other, it would no longer matter which faction they stay in.

And even if they stay in Yuan's faction, they are still affiliated with the Spiritual Elites and the Six Spiritual Families by blood.

"Thank you all for coming here," Yuan said to them.

"It's actually a pleasure for us to be here! When do you want to create your faction?" Wang Ming then asked.

"We can do that right now. Just give us a moment to prepare and we'll head out."

"Okay."

A few minutes later, Yuan and Meixiu wore their masks before going outside.

"In order to create our faction, we'll need to head to the Cultivators' Association," Meixiu said.

"The Cultivators' Association? I didn't think we would go back there so soon..." Yuan sighed.

Chapter 601 - Demon Sealing Faction

"Yuan, I have been wondering this ever since I learned that you were blind... But how do you see where you're going? You can move and even fight better than most people who can see... I almost didn't believe it when I first heard it." Wang Ming said to him as they walked down the street as one big group.

"Although I am blind... I am not actually blind. I can see using divine sense." Yuan said, and he began explaining to them about divine sense.

"The grand elders are Spirit Masters as well, but they cannot use divine sense." Wang Bingbing shook her head.

"By the way, what's the faction going to be called?" Shi Lang then asked.

"Demon Sealing Faction," Yuan calmly responded.

"D-Demon Sealing...?" They all looked at him with wide eyes.

"Does this mean..."

"Yes, our purpose is to deal with the demons that will eventually break out of their seal. Of course, I don't actually expect any of you to fight the demons. I can handle them alone, but if you wish to learn how to seal demons, I can teach you."

"Really?! You'll teach us how to defeat demons?!" Wang Ming exclaimed in an excited voice.

After what happened at the Jaded Garden, he wished that he had the ability to fight demons.

"If that's what you want." Yuan nodded.

Sometime later, they arrived at the Cultivators' Association that was as busy as ever with cultivators mostly at the Spirit Apprentice level walking around.

Yuan took a deep breath, clearing the bad memories he had in this place, before walking inside with the others.

Upon entering the building, Meixiu said, "Follow me."

She brought them to the faction area, where people go to create or advertise their factions.

"Hello, how may I help you?" The receptionist sitting behind the desk asked.

"We're here to register for a new faction," Meixiu said.

"A new faction, right? Do you wish to be an official faction or merely a faction in name?" The receptionist then asked.

"What's the difference?"

"In order to become an official faction, you must pay a certain fee to be registered in the official faction list. As an official faction, you will get to advertise at our Cultivators' Association and receive recognition from the government."

"If you only want to be a faction in name, you will still be registered in the system, but you won't be recognized as a real faction." The receptionist explained.

"So it's all about the money in the end, huh?" Wang Ming laughed.

And he continued, "I don't think we need to pay them to be an official faction. Once the people realize who is running the faction, they will have no choice but to consider us official, right, Yuan?"

'W-Wait... Did he just say 'Yuan'?' The receptionist doubted his ears.

Then he realized that two of them were wearing masks, something Player Yuan was known for.

"A-Are you perhaps Player Yuan?" The receptionist asked the one that emitted the stronger presence.

"Yes, I am." Yuan calmly responded.

"P-Please give me a moment..."

The receptionist then picked up the phone and dialed a number.

"Yes... Player Yuan is here at desk number 3..."

The receptionist hung up after that sentence and returned to them with a nervous smile on his face.

"Our chairman will personally take care of you, esteemed guests," he said.

Two minutes later, they could see a middle-aged man with a short but neat beard running in their direction.

"W-Welcome to the Cultivators' Association, Player Yuan! I am Chairman Lee, Chairman Zhao's replacement following his resignation. First and foremost, allow me to personally apologize for what happened previously. I promise that no such thing will ever happen again as long as I am the Chairman." Chairman Lee respectfully bowed to them.

This attracted the people there.

"Hey... Isn't that person with the black mask Player Yuan? What's he doing back at the Cultivators' Association? Did they offend him again?"

Meanwhile, Yuan remained calm and said, "What happened in the past has nothing to do with you, so I don't understand why you feel the need to apologize to me. Just let it go."

"Thank you for your pardon. Now then, how may I help you?"

"We're here to start our own faction," Yuan said.

"Of course. Allow me to help you." Chairman Lee then turned to look at the receptionist with an intensive gaze.

The receptionist quickly stepped aside to allow Chairman Lee to get behind the desk. This is the first time the receptionist has seen Chairman Lee so eager to work their job.

"Alright, I am ready. I just need the details now— Oh, right. I nearly forgot. You need at least 10 people to create a faction, or I won't be able to register it in the system."

"We have ten people here," Yuan said.

"Great. Then let's start with the name of the faction."

"Demon Sealing Faction," Yuan immediately said.

"D-Demon...?" Chairman Lee looked at Yuan with a dazed face for a good moment before snapping out of it and typing it into the computer.

"As for the leader of the faction... I am assuming it's going to be you?" Chairman Lee asked him a moment later.

"Who else is more qualified to be the leader than him here?" Li Jinxi sneered, almost as though she was mocking his question.

"I-I understand... What about the vice-leaders? You can have two of them at most."

Yuan then said, "Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang."

After typing their name into the system, Chairman Lee spoke, "Can I have the others' name now?"

Wang Ming and the others began giving their names one by one.

Once all of their names were in the system, Chairman Lee created their faction.

Normally, a newly registered faction would need to be vetted first before they are approved, but with Chairman Lee's position within the Cultivators' Association, they easily skipped all of those steps and instantly got approved as an official faction.

"Congratulations, your faction 'Demon Sealing Faction' has been created. If you ever need anything or have any questions, you are free to contact me at any time and I will do my best to help you..." Chairman Lee said to them afterward.

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Chapter 602 - Qi Device

"Does this mean we are done here?" Yuan asked after their faction was created.

"Not completely. Your faction has been created, but we still need some more information, such as the location of your faction headquarters, and if you want, you can register your members' cultivation base into the system so that we can rank your faction." Chairman Lee said.

And he continued, "Of course, the higher rank your faction, the more benefit you can receive."

"The location of our faction?" Yuan mumbled.

"What if we don't have a location yet?" He then asked.

"That's completely fine. It's not required to have a headquarter for your faction, but most factions have one, as it makes them look more professional. Also, it would make things more convenient for the members if they can all live in the same area."

Yuan turned around and asked the others, "Well? What do you guys think?"

"We don't have any living quarters at the moment since we weren't sure if you wanted us to stay afterward, but we can live in hotels or rent out someplace near your apartment if it's too much to get our own headquarters since they're not cheap." Wang Ming said.

"If it's a money issue, we can simply ask our families for help." Li Jinxi said calmly.

"I think it's more of a location issue since I don't have any ideas where we should make our headquarters," Yuan said.

"If you need help looking for a headquarter, our Cultivators' Association can help you. We have specialists for this kind of stuff. We will help you scout out areas based on your preferences, and we can give out loans with zero interest if you need help with money." Chairman Lee suddenly said, realizing that this is a perfect opportunity to make things right between the Cultivators' Association and Yuan, whose faction will surely become a top power in the near future.

Yuan pondered for a moment before nodding his head, "Okay, we'll rely on you to scout for a place."

"Very well! Just let me know the details and the Cultivators' Association will do everything in its power to find you a suitable place! Are there any more questions?"

"Then can you tell me about the faction ranking and what kind of benefit we can receive?" Yuan then asked.

"Of course! Every faction can be ranked depending on its overall prowess and influence. From the lowest rank to the highest, we have Bronze, Silver, Gold, Platinum, and lastly, Crimson."

"As for the benefits... You can receive monthly allowances and assistance from the Cultivators' Association and all of our allies." Chairman Lee then continued.

"The rank and benefits only matter if you join the Cultivators' Association. The Spiritual Elites doesn't have any rank because we didn't join the Cultivators' Association, but we would easily qualify for the highest rank." Wang Ming said.

"I see..." Yuan nodded.

"Actually, you can still receive an official rank and some benefits even if you don't join the Cultivators' Association. It just won't compare to those

who join our Cultivators' Association, and it'll be harder to get approved." Chairman Lee explained.

"If we don't have to join the Cultivators' Association to receive a rank, we will do it." Yuan then said.

Even though he couldn't care less about their rank, he wanted to see how they compared to the other factions.

"Very well. Please give me a moment."

Chairman Lee then retrieved something from under the desk.

"This is a Qi Device, it can analyze spiritual energy and determine one's cultivation with fairly good accuracy. It was only created very recently as well. Try it out."

Yuan and the others looked at this machine with raised eyebrows.

"Here, let me show you." Chairman Lee then placed his hand on this machine before pressing a red button.

A few moments later, the words 'Ninth Level Spirit Apprentice' appeared on the screen.

"Let me try next!" Wang Ming was the first one amongst them to try out the machine.

After putting his hands on the machine, he waited for the results.

"T-Third Level Spirit Warrior?!" Chairman Lee's eyes widened with shock when he saw the results.

"Third level? That's not right. I'm actually at the seventh level Spirit Warrior." Wang Ming corrected him.

"What?" Chairman Lee looked at Wang Ming with a look of disbelief on his face.

"Maybe the machine isn't ready for cultivators above Spirit Warrior since most people are still Spirit Apprentices." Shi Lang said.

"That makes sense." Wang Ming nodded.

"If that's the case, there's no point for the rest of us to try it since we're all above Spirit Warrior and it won't be able to accurately tell our cultivation." Xi Murong said.

Chairman Lee was left speechless by Xi Murong's words. They were all above Spirit Warrior? Where on earth did so many geniuses come from?

"I-I am sorry for the inconveniences. It will probably take some more time before these machines can handle Spirit Warriors..." Chairman Lee apologized to them.

"It might even take a few years before they can handle Yuan, who is already a Spirit Master." Wang Ming laughed out loud.

"Anyways, since we cannot accurately gauge your cultivation level, let's just focus on your headquarters for now. What kind of preferences do you have in mind? Such as the scenery, the size of the building, and your budget."

Yuan pondered for a moment before speaking, "I don't really care about the scenery or the location as it's in a convenient area. As for the size of the place... I would prefer it if it could fit over 10, even 20 people comfortably. As for our budget... it doesn't matter either."

Chairman Lee continued to ask Yuan a few more questions about what he wanted for their headquarters.

Fifteen minutes later, Chairman Lee nodded, "All done. Please give us a week to scout for your headquarters. I will notify you the moment we finish."

"Okay." Yuan nodded.

"It was a pleasure helping you. I look forward to the day your faction reaches the top." Chairman Lee said to them before leaving the scene.

Yuan and the others left the Cultivators' Association shortly afterward.

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Chapter 603 - Returning To Cultivation Online

"Where will you guys be staying until we have our headquarters?" Yuan asked Wang Ming and the others.

"We'll probably rent a hotel somewhere close to your apartment. It'll only be for around a week, anyway." Wang Ming said.

"What about you? What are you going to be doing in the meantime?" Li Jinxi asked him, as she was hoping to train with him while they waited.

"I am going to return to Cultivation Online. It's been a very long time since I last stepped foot in that world, after all," he said.

"Cultivation Online?" The elite disciples raised their eyebrows simultaneously.

Although they have played Cultivation Online before, none of them took it seriously.

'Maybe he wants to get his mind off that incident by indulging himself in Cultivation Online...'

All of the elite disciples had a similar thought, so they didn't question him.

Sometime later, Yuan and the elite disciples went their separate ways.

"I didn't think he'd really allow us to stay." Xi Murong said once they left.

"Why not? He's a very nice guy if you get to know him." Wang Ming said.

"Really? I feel nervous when he's around. His presence is extraordinary."

"That doesn't mean he's a bad person. In fact, he can be quite humble at times."

"Anyways, let's hurry up and find a hotel. I need to tell my parents that Yuan has officially created his faction." Shi Lang said.

Meanwhile, back at the apartment, Yuan said, "Now that I have created my faction, I will leave everything else to you two, Meixiu, Lulu."

"I promise you that I will make it the best faction in the world!" Chu Liuxiang proudly patted her chest.

"What will the requirements be like? If we're even going to accept new members." Meixiu then asked.

"I don't think we need any new members, and I don't like the idea of recruiting people that we don't know just for the sake of increasing our members," he said.

"Makes sense. Then what should we do?"

"I think we can scout for headquarters even though the Cultivators' Association is already helping us with that." Chu Liuxiang suddenly said.

"Sebastian, bring my laptop."

"Yes, Young Lady."

Sebastian then retrieved a thin laptop from their luggage before putting it on the desk.

Chu Liuxiang opened the laptop and opened up a browser.

"We can look for headquarters using this. My Chu Family has an intelligence agency, and I have special access to the system, so I can look at pretty much anything I want from this laptop."

While Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang looked at potential buildings they could use as headquarters for their faction, Yuan went inside his room and retrieved the console that allowed people to play Cultivation Online.

However, he no longer looked at the console in the same light as before, especially now that he knows Cultivation Online is a real world and this console somehow teleports them there.

Yuan laid on the bed, and after taking a deep breath, he wore the console on his head.

After turning the power on, Yuan could feel his consciousness being sucked away. He could feel himself flying through the void, and this feeling would last for a few seconds until he appeared inside Cultivation Online.

Once he was back inside Cultivation Online, Yuan took a deep breath.

"It feels like forever since I last logged on," he mumbled as he looked at the scenery with his eyes.

"After using nothing but divine sense for the last few weeks, it feels weird using my eyes to see."

"I wonder what the others have been up to..." Yuan tried to contact them using their servant and master connection, but nobody responded to him, meaning they were too far away for the connection to work.

Yuan looked at the sky and sighed, "Even though I have returned, where am I supposed to start? Where do I go for answers?"

"The upper heavens... Maybe I can find my answers there, but I cannot go there without Xiao Hua and the others..."

After pondering for a moment, Yuan decided to prepare for the Stairway to Heaven while he waits for Xiao Hua and the others to return.

However, he wasn't sure where to start.

Then he remembered a certain promise he made with somebody.

"That's right... I promised Senior Song that I'd visit her sect before I departed the Lower Heavens... Since she's also a top expert in this world, maybe she knows something about the Stairway to Heaven."

"Heavenly Melody Academy, huh."

Yuan then returned to the nearest city to ask around for the location of the Heavenly Melody Academy.

Once he got the directions, Yuan went to the nearest teleportation device to teleport to the city that was closest to the Heavenly Melody Academy, before flying to the sect on his flying sword.

While he traveled to the Heavenly Melody Academy alone, Yuan realized that this was his first time traveling a long distance by himself.

Ever since he met Xiao Hua at the very beginning of his journey, he would always have somebody by his side.

'It feels so weird being alone, it's also a new experience at the same time...'

A few hours later, Yuan arrived at the Heavenly Melody Academy, and even at the sect's entrance, he could already hear music being played in the distance.

"How can we help you?" The disciples guarding the gate asked him when he approached.

"I'm here to see Senior Song, your Sect Master."

"Sect Master Song? Who are you? Do you have an appointment with her?" The disciples immediately doubted his identity, as their Sect Master rarely receives any guests, and Yuan looked too young to be of any importance to their Sect Master.

It was at this moment Yuan recalled that Song Ling'er had given him a jade slip so that he could contact her.

Thus, Yuan no longer bothered with the disciples and retrieved the jade slip, sending Song Ling'er a message.

"I am currently outside the Heavenly Melody Academy."

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Chapter 604 - Heavenly Melody Academy

"Sect Master, regarding this year's disciple recruitment..."

A group of high-ranking sect elders stood before Song Ling'er as they talked about their future plans for the Heavenly Melody Academy.

However, midway through their meeting, Song Ling'er noticed that one of her communication jade slips was trembling, and it was the one that she'd been anticipating for the longest.

Seeing this, Song Ling'er immediately listened to the message from it.

"I am currently outside the Heavenly Melody Academy." Yuan's voice resounded.

"He's finally here!" Song Ling'er stood up and shouted in an excited voice.

This startled the sect elders, and they all proceeded to stare at her with puzzled looks.

"The meeting will end early today. We'll continue this at another date." Song Ling'er said to them before leaving the scene in a hurry without explaining to them the situation.

The sect elders could only speculate that something serious must have happened to cause her to leave with such urgency.

Little did they know that she was only going to greet a young man at the entrance of their sect.

Once Song Ling'er left the meeting, she quickly sent Yuan a message stating that she will be there shortly.

Meanwhile, outside the Heavenly Melody Academy, the disciples guarding the gates said to Yuan, who had been standing outside their sect for a while now, "Excuse me, but you cannot linger outside the sect, so you'll have to leave."

"I am waiting for your Sect Master, who should be arriving here now." Yuan said to them in a calm voice.

The disciples looked at each other before laughing out loud, "The Sect Master is coming here? Who do you think you are? The Sect Master has never greeted anyone at the entrance before!"

"I don't know what else to tell you if you're not going to believe me." Yuan shook his head.

Now that he understood why the 'NPCs' act like real humans, he no longer saw them in the same light as before.

The disciples then approached him and said, "If you're not going to leave, we'll make you leave!"

"Are you sure you want me to leave?" Yuan looked at them with a nonchalant gaze.

"Do you think we're joking?!" The disciples then retrieved their weapons, but it wasn't what one would normally expect, as they were instruments instead of actual weapons.

Yuan merely shook his head and turned around, before walking away.

Of course, he didn't actually leave the place.

Once he was out of the disciples' sight, he stopped and began waiting there, as he was in no mood to deal with the unreasonable disciples.

After all, the easiest way to deal with these types of people is simply to avoid them, and arguing with them would only escalate the situation.

A few minutes after Yuan left the place, Song Ling'er showed up at the scene, which shocked the disciples there.

"S-Sect Master? What are you doing here?" The disciples guarding the gate asked after greeting her.

They had a clue why she was there, but they didn't want to believe it, as they would definitely be punished if it was true.

Song Ling'er didn't answer their question and instead looked around, but when she couldn't see Yuan anywhere, she frowned.

"Hey, was there a young man here just now? He should be around your age. Black hair." Song Ling'er decided to ask the disciples, as she didn't think Yuan would be the type to play such a cruel trick on her.

The disciples immediately felt as though they'd been slapped in the face when they realized who Song Ling'er was referring to, and they cried inwardly, 'So he was actually telling the truth! And we chased him away! We're doomed!'

"S-Sect Master... W-What had happened was..."

The disciples began trying to give excuses, but Song Ling'er didn't care about any of that, and she asked again, "Did you see him or not?"

"W-We did..."

"Where is he then?"

"We thought he was someone suspicious, so we kind of forced him to leave..." One of the disciples eventually resigned to his fate and revealed the truth.

"You what?!"

As they'd expected, Song Ling'er immediately fumed with anger.

"We're sorry, Sect Master! We really didn't know he was telling the truth!"

The disciples quickly got on their knees and begged for forgiveness.

After a moment of silence, Song Ling'er spoke in a cold voice, "If you're really sorry, then go bring him back! And you're all forbidden to return until you do!"

The disciples felt like crying after hearing her words that low-key expelled them from the sect.

However, right as tears began forming in the corner of their eyes, Song Ling'er noticed a figure approaching them from a distance.

When she saw Yuan's face, her cold face immediately softened.

"Yuan!" She called out to him, causing the disciples to turn their heads.

When they saw the young man they'd turned away return, their eyes glistened with hope and joy.

"I apologize for making you wait even though I messaged you earlier." Yuan said to her.

"Don't worry about it, I have heard the situation from these idiots. Please forgive their rudeness just now." Song Ling'er shook her head.

And she continued, "Follow me, let me show you around the sect before we sit down."

Yuan nodded and proceeded to follow her.

The disciples sighed in relief inwardly when they saw them leaving, but alas, Song Ling'er suddenly said, "All of you here will spend 1 month in the chamber of repentance starting today."

"Y-Yes, Sect Master!" They all responded simultaneously.

Although they were still getting punished, it was much better than getting kicked out of the sect that they worked so hard to enter.

Once they entered the sect, Song Ling'er began guiding Yuan around the Heavenly Melody Academy.

"Since you're here, does it mean you'll be challenging the Stairway to Heaven soon?" Song Ling'er asked him as they walked around the sect.

"Yes... I wanted to explore the Lower Heavens a little more before, but alas... Looks like I will have to postpone that plan for the future."

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Chapter 605 - Two Statues

"Leaving it for the future? You know it's going to be very difficult for you to return once you ascend, right? Especially the higher you go, the more resources it'll require for you to come back to the Lower Heavens," Song Ling'er said to him.

"I know, but it's not impossible."

Song Ling'er stared at him in silence for a moment before speaking, "Did something happen? There's something different about you."

"Huh? How can you tell?"

"A woman's intuition, I guess," she casually shrugged.

Yuan then sighed, "Something did happen, but it's all in the past now, and dwelling on it won't do me any good."

"While it's definitely not worth dwelling on some things, some definitely are worth it, as it could be what pushes you further past your limit. If you want to talk to me about it, I am all ears."

Yuan pondered for a moment before asking, "Senior Song... Do you know anyone close to you that have passed away? Sorry if it's a sensitive question."

Song Ling'er looked at him with raised eyebrows, "Death? This is the cultivation world, where death is probably one of if not the most common thing regardless of which realm you're in. I don't think there is anyone around my age that hasn't experienced the death of a friend or a loved one."

"In fact, I have lost many friends to magical beasts and even more to other cultivators. I thought it was something more serious, but I guess this is your first time experiencing something like this, which is pretty normal."

Yuan nodded and said, "Yes, this is the first time someone close to me has passed away, and she was even killed right before my eyes. How did you deal with the loss of a friend?"

Song Ling'er looked up at the sky and said in a low voice, "You can never completely deal with the loss of a friend or family member— at least I don't think so, since they will always remain in your memories. The best thing one can do is try to prevent it from happening again in the future. Other than that, you'll just have to live the rest of your life with that burden, especially if you're the reason that person died."

"Many people— friends had died because I was too weak to protect them. And as cold-hearted as this may sound, it's because of their death that pushed me to where I am today, so I am also grateful to them in a way."

"Become strong enough so that it doesn't happen again, huh..." Yuan mumbled in a low voice.

"I don't know what happened, but as a cultivator— especially as a musician, you must learn how to control your emotions."

"I understand. Thank you for the advice, Senior Song."

Yuan suddenly stopped walking when he noticed something in the distance — two large statues standing beside each other with a zither in their grasp.

"Can I get a closer look at those statues?" Yuan pointed to them and asked.

"Of course."

Once they were before the statue, Yuan focused on the female statue to his left first, as it resembled someone that he has seen before.

"This person... She looks like the Zither Goddess." Yuan mumbled out loud.

"That is because she is the Zither Goddess," said Song Ling'er.

And she continued, "Most people that aren't a disciple of this sect don't know this, but the Zither Goddess used to be a disciple of our Heavenly Melody Academy. Unfortunately, she didn't stay for long because she easily surpassed everyone within just a few years."

"The Zither Goddess was a disciple here? What was she like as a disciple?" Yuan asked, his interest piqued.

"This is what I heard from the previous Sect Master, who heard it from the previous Sect Master and so on, but the Zither Goddess was a quiet girl who would spend the majority of her time alone in this exact spot playing the zither. If she's not here, then she would be in her own room playing the zither."

"Is there a reason why she would spend so much time here? I don't see anything special here." Yuan looked around, but he could only see an empty area beside the statues.

Song Ling'er then pointed to the statue standing right beside the Zither Goddess' statue.

"It's because of this statue. She would spend most of her time performing for this statue," she said.

Yuan turned his focus onto the second statue, which was a statue of a handsome man.

"Are they perhaps acquainted with each other?" Yuan couldn't help but ask.

Song Ling'er chuckled a little before responding, "That's not possible. That person left the Lower Heavens millions of years ago while the Zither Goddess wasn't born until around 25,000 years ago."

"If you ask me, I think it's because she admires this person, hence why she had spent most of her time here."

"The Zither Goddess admiring somebody? He must be a fairly influential person."

"If you consider the God of Music an influential person, then you're right." Song Ling'er said.

"Eh? So he's the God of Music? Does this mean he was also a disciple of the Heavenly Melody Academy?"

"If only. The Heavenly Melody Academy is only a hundred thousand years old, after all. We made the statue to pay our respects to the God of Music, who is known to have complete mastery over every instrument in existence."

"Is that so..." Yuan looked at the face of the God of Music.

Seeing Yuan staring at the God of Music's face, she said, "By the way, that's not really the God of Music's real appearance. The statue was made only based on some descriptions of him from ancient scrolls. I don't think anyone in the Lower Heavens would know his appearance."

"Does this mean he still exists somewhere in the upper heavens?" Yuan then asked.

"I don't know, but if you ask me... I don't think anyone can live for millions of years even if they are the God of Music," she calmly responded.

Chapter 606 - Paying Respects

"If he's the God of Music, he should have a very high cultivation base, right? I heard that cultivators who can live forever exist in the upper heavens." Yuan said.

"You mean true immortals? These people can be counted with one hand... And while he was recognized as the God of Music, that doesn't automatically make him a powerful cultivator. Perhaps if he was called the God of Cultivation, it would make more sense." Song Ling'er said.

"The God of Music, huh? I wonder what kind of person he was." Yuan mumbled to himself.

"Unfortunately, not much is known about the God of Music besides his name— Tian Kai."

Yuan raised his eyebrows after hearing the surname 'Tian', as it sounded familiar for some reason.

"Their surnames are also 'Tian'..." Yuan thought to himself.

After a moment of silence, Yuan asked Song Ling'er, "Do you mind if I play a song here?"

"Right now?" Song Ling'er raised her eyebrows.

"Yes, I want to pay my respects to both of them the same way the Zither Goddess paid respect to the God of Music."

"Go ahead."

Yuan then retrieved the Soul Ensnaring Zither before taking a seat right before the two statues.

After taking a deep breath, he began playing Zither Goddess's Ethereal Arts.

Ding~

A ripple swept the Heavenly Melody Academy every time Yuan played a music note on the Soul Ensnaring Zither.

Song Ling'er's eyes widened with shock as she watched his performance, as compared to the time he played during the zither competition, he has improved by leaps and bounds.

The song didn't last long, only a little over a minute, but it was more than long enough to mesmerize those who heard it, and they would all look as though their soul was absorbed out of their body, resembling Yuan when he first witnessed the Zither Goddess' performance.

Yuan stood up and returned the zither back inside his storage ring after the song ended.

"Have you been practicing recently?" Song Ling'er asked him when she eventually snapped out of her daze.

"Hm? Not really," he said.

Although he did play for a few days with Azure, it couldn't really be counted as practice.

"I really cannot fathom why someone like you would focus on other things when you're already extremely talented with the zither." Song Ling'er shook her head in a regretful manner, as she truly believed that it was a loss for the world of music that Yuan chose a different path.

"Anyways, if you are done here, let's go to my place, where we can sit down and talk more."

"Yes, I am done here."

Thus, Yuan began following Song Ling'er to the Sect Master's headquarters.

"I have been wondering for a while now... With so many people playing different instruments out in the open, won't they just disturb each other?" Yuan asked as they walked.

"Yes, that's the point." Song Ling'er nodded.

"They are trying to disturb others while focusing on their own music, as this cultivates their mind and concentration."

"I see... That makes sense."

"Of course, if a disciple wants to play privately, there are plenty of places they can go for that."

While Yuan and Song Ling'er approached the Sect Master's headquarters, the disciples that heard Yuan's performance began spreading rumors.

"Hey, did you hear that performance just now? Who was playing?"

"If you ask me, I think only the Sect Master can play the zither with such perfection."

"No, I have been to many of the Sect Master's performances, and I can say with certainty that it's not her. I dare say whoever played the zither just now is even better than the Sect Master!"

"Even better than the Sect Master? How is that possible? The Sect Master is the number one zither expert in the Lower Heavens!"

"I don't care who this person is— I just want to listen more to their performance!"

After arriving at the Sect Master's headquarters, Song Ling'er brought Yuan to her room, where they sat down with tea in their hands.

"You'll be challenging the Stairway to Heaven soon, right? What are you going to do once you ascend to the next realm?" Song Ling'er asked him

once they were relaxed.

"I am going to continue climbing until I have answers to my questions," he said.

"Questions? What kind of questions?"

Yuan looked at her in silence for a moment before speaking, "Do you know of a place called Earth?"

"Earth? No," she immediately responded.

"What kind of place is this Earth?"

"It's my hometown," he said.

"What if I told you that I came from another world?" Yuan suddenly asked her.

"Another world? You mean you came from the upper heavens? I wouldn't be surprised if that was the case," she said.

"No... Not the upper heavens. I mean like a completely different world... Another planet."

Song Ling'er looked at him with a puzzled expression, seemingly unable to comprehend his words.

"Nevermind... Let me change the question. Can you tell me a little more about the Stairway to Heaven? I know there are challenges that await within the Stairway to Heaven, but what kind of challenges?"

"The challenge is different for each person challenging the Stairway to Heaven, so I cannot tell you what you might experience. However, I can tell you my experience with the Stairway to Heaven."

"Eh? You've challenged the Stairway to Heaven before?"

"Yes, I have... And before you think I failed the challenges, I will have you know that I'd intentionally failed the last challenge because I didn't want to ascend."

"You don't want to ascend? But I thought it was every cultivators' desire to climb higher."

"For most cultivators, yes, that is the case, but I am content with my current standing. I am the Sect Master of the Heavenly Melody Academy. If I leave the Lower Heavens, I will have to start climbing from the bottom again. Furthermore, I don't have anybody who can replace my position as Sect Master. If I leave now, the Heavenly Melody Academy will suffer..." Song Ling'er explained.

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Chapter 607 - Music Pagoda

"Maybe in the future when I have someone who is capable of replacing me as Sect Master, I will challenge the Stairway to Heaven again."

"Anyways, for the Stairway to Heaven, when I challenged it, I had to do 4 trials."

"For the first trial, I had to fight a stampede of magical beasts that was two levels above my cultivation."

"For the second trial, I had to traverse a thousand miles while being burdened by a powerful pressure and magical beasts."

"For the third trial, I had to confront my heart demon."

"And for the final trial, I had to fight another magical beast, but this time, it was five whole levels above my cultivation."

"Although the trials are random for everyone, many people have received the same trial before, so there's a good chance that you'll experience some of the same trials I went through."

"I see... This information will definitely be helpful to me. Thank you, Senior Song. If there's anything I can do in return, don't hesitate to ask."
Yuan said to her.

"I do have one request for you. Can you do a performance before the disciples for me? I want to broaden their views. Most of them think I am the number one zither expert under heaven, but that is far from the truth, as there are plenty more skillful zither experts in the upper heavens."

"Okay. I don't mind if it's just a performance. When do you want me to do it?"

"I will need some time to prepare for it. Can you give me four— No, three days? You can even stay here as an esteemed guest if you'd like."

"Sure." Yuan nodded.

After all, he doesn't know where Xiao Hua and the others were or when they'll return, and there was no way that he'd leave them behind to challenge the Stairway to Heaven. Furthermore, he still has to return to the Dragon Essence Temple to pick Min Li up as he'd promised.

Sometime later, Senior Song led Yuan to his living quarters where he'll be spending the next three days.

"My house is this one, so if you need anything, just knock on my door. Though I usually spend most of my time at the Sect Master's headquarters, so you can find me there if I am not home."

"You are also free to wander the sect, but there are some restricted areas that can only be accessed by certain individuals."

"Do you have a place where I can learn new songs?" Yuan then asked.

"Of course. Just go to the Music Pagoda. You'll find thousands of songs there."

"Thank you."

"Also, take this with you. This is proof that you're a guest at our sect. If you're caught without it, you might be misunderstood like what happened earlier, so make sure you have it with you at all times when you leave your living quarters." Song Ling'er handed him a medallion before returning to the Sect Master's headquarters.

Once she left, Yuan looked around his living quarters before making his way to the Melody Pavilion that Song Ling'er had mentioned.

"Excuse me, do you know the way to Music Pagoda?" Yuan asked the first disciple he encountered.

And since he was living beside Song Ling'er's living quarters, it was only natural that he was located in the center of the sect with the elites.

"Who are you? I don't recognize your face. You new here?" The young man asked Yuan.

"No, I am just here as a guest," he said.

'A guest that can enter the inner courts of the sect? Just who is this guy?' The young man wondered to himself.

"The Music Pagoda is at the Outer Court. You can get there by following that path over there. As for the place itself, it's an eleven-story building. You won't miss it."

"Thank you for the information," Yuan said to him before following the path.

Sometime later, Yuan arrived at the Outer Court, where disciples could be seen walking around with all kinds of instruments in their grasp.

The most common instrument appeared to be the zither, which was expected since their Sect Master is a zither expert, but it wasn't to the point where it overwhelmed the other instruments.

There was a good variety of instruments, and Yuan began thinking of trying all of them before leaving.

Eventually, he arrived at the Music Pagoda, which was crowded with disciples.

After looking around the place, Yuan decided to enter the building, and to his surprise, it was much more spacious than he'd anticipated.

He approached one of the hundreds of shelves there and picked up a random scroll to read the contents.

It was a music sheet for the flute.

He picked up another from the same shelf, and it was also for the flute.

It was at this moment that Yuan noticed the tag at the side of the shelf that read 'Flute'.

Yuan then walked around until he found the zither tag.

Once he did, he began looking through the music sheets one by one until he read everything on the shelf.

When the disciples around him saw this, they thought that he was looking for the perfect song, but little did they know he was actually memorizing the songs so that he could try them all out later.

"There are eleven floors in this building and the first floor is already filled with hundreds of songs. It'll probably take months if I want to learn every song in this place..." Yuan mumbled to himself as he looked for the next shelf of zither music.

Meanwhile, Song Ling'er was preparing for Yuan's concert in three days.

"You want to gather all of the disciples three days from now? What is the special occasion?" One of the sect elders asked her after receiving this sudden order.

"There will be a performance on that day. I believe that it will greatly benefit the disciples, perhaps even change their lives once they witness the performance," she said.

"A performance? By whom?"

"An expert that's even better than me," she casually responded, leaving them speechless.

Chapter 608 - Prove It!

"Even better than you, Sect Master? Who is this person?" One of the sect elders asked.

"You'll find out in three days," she casually responded.

Meanwhile, back at the Music Pagoda, Yuan decided to see if the music sheets on the second floor were any different.

"There are more notes... I guess the higher the floor the more difficult the songs."

Now that he had this knowledge, he wanted to see what was the most difficult song in this place, so he began making his way towards the 11th floor.

Once he reached the 11th floor, he walked straight to the zither section and began looking through the music sheets one by one.

"Oh? I recognize this song..." Yuan was surprised by the first music sheet that he'd randomly picked, and it was the same song that he'd played during the zither competition after learning it from Song Ling'er's disciples.

Even though he already knew the song, he still wanted to look at the music sheet properly to get a better understanding of it.

While Yuan looked at this music sheet, a disciple approached him from behind.

"Hey, you're blocking the shelf." This disciple said to him.

"Oh, I am sorry." Yuan turned around to see a beautiful young lady standing behind him, and she looked very familiar for some reason.

'Isn't she from the zither competition?'

It took a moment for Yuan to recognize this girl, who was the one that played the incredible song 'God Descends from Heaven' during the zither competition.

However, this girl didn't recognize Yuan, who wasn't wearing a mask at this moment but did during the zither competition.

As Yuan made way for her, she noticed the music note in his grasp.

'God Descends from Heaven? Who is this guy?'

Besides the top disciples in the sect that want to challenge themselves, most people don't even dare to pick up the song because of its difficulty.

"Do you intend on learning that song?" Ai Wan asked him out of curiosity.

"Eh? No, I already know the song," he subconsciously responded.

"You can play God Descends from Heaven?" Ai Wan looked at him with a suspicious face.

Even many sect elders do not dare say that they 'know' the song, yet this random person dares to make such claims?

"Yes, I can."

"Just because you can play a few hundred notes out of a few thousand doesn't mean you can play the song."

"No, I can play the entire song."

"I don't believe you." Ai Wan quickly said.

And she continued, "Prove it! If you can really play the whole song, I will call you master!"

"It's fine, I don't really need to prove myself." Yuan calmly said.

"I knew it! There's no way a nobody like you can play the most difficult song in the Lower Heavens!" Ai Wan felt insulted by Yuan when he claimed to know the song, as she had spent many years learning the song, and claiming you can play a song when you actually can't is a taboo within the sect.

The other disciples on that floor noticed their commotion and joined the fun.

"What's going on, Senior Sister Ai? Why are you arguing with this guy?"

"Did he offend Senior Sister? I will immediately take care of him for you!"

Yuan suddenly found himself surrounded by these disciples, causing him to shake his head.

"I just need to prove that I can play the song, right? Alright, I will play the song for you."

Yuan retrieved the Soul Ensnaring Zither on the spot and took a seat while still surrounded by the disciples.

'W-Wait a second... That zither... It can't be?!' Ai Wan immediately recognized the Soul Ensnaring Zither, as she'd tried to play it before but to no avail.

But before she could think too much, Yuan started playing the zither, instantly putting them in a daze.

"Who dares to play their instrument inside the Music Pagoda?!" The sect elders managing the building frowned when they heard music coming from the top, as it was against the rules to play one's instrument inside the building.

However, they stopped moving when they realized the song that was being played.

"T-This song is God Descends from Heaven!"

"Who is playing right now?!"

The disciples there also realized this fact, and everybody began making their way to the 11th floor, quickly overwhelming the place.

"Get out of my way!"

"You get out of my way!"

The disciples began shoving each other around just to move a single step forward.

"Make way!"

The sect elders eventually arrived and forced the disciples to make a clear path for them.

However, by the time they arrived on the 11th floor, Yuan had already finished the song, playing every single note of God Descends from Heaven flawlessly without making a single mistake this time.

[Your stats has been increased by 50% for 1 hour from the effects of 'God Descending from Heaven']

Yuan stored the Soul Ensnaring Zither before standing up and looking at Ai Wan, who was standing there with a dazed look on her face.

"Are you happy now?" Yuan asked her.

It was at this moment Ai Wan finally recognized his voice.

"Wait... You... You're that masked man during the zither competition! What are you doing here?!" She exclaimed in a shocked voice.

The sect elders arrived at this moment and said, "Who was playing just now?"

The disciples there immediately pointed at Yuan.

"Let me see your disciple identification badge." The sect elder approached Yuan.

"I am not a disciple here," Yuan said, showing them the medallion that Song Ling'er had given him.

"Not a disciple?" The sect elders were speechless.

How can such a talented individual not be a part of their sect? That in itself should be a crime!

"Although that was an amazing performance just now, it's against the rules to play your instrument in the Music Pagoda." The sect elder said after snapping out of his daze.

"Eh? I didn't know that, sorry." Yuan immediately apologized.

"This was all my fault, elders. If you're going to hold anyone responsible, it should be me." Ai Wan suddenly stepped forward and said.

"Prime Disciple Ai?" The sect elders looked at her with wide eyes, as Ai Wan is usually a quiet girl who never causes any trouble.

Chapter 609 - Zither Goddess

Immortal Cave

Chapter 609 - Zither Goddess's Immortal Cave

"W-Well... Since Prime Disciple Ai says so... We'll forget about this incident. However, make sure it doesn't happen again, or the Sect Master will be very upset with you." The sect elder said to her.

Because Ai Wan was Song Ling'er's disciple, the other sect elders didn't dare to punish her, as they believed that they would be overstepping their boundaries as a sect elder to discipline the Sect Master's disciple.

"Thank you, sect elders. This will not happen again." Ai Wan bowed to them.

She then glanced at Yuan for a moment before leaving the Music Pagoda.

Yuan also decided to leave since it would be impossible to look at the music sheets in peace after that little commotion.

Once he left the Music Pagoda, Yuan noticed Ai Wan standing outside, almost like she was waiting for him.

"I'm sorry for acting up just now," she suddenly said to him.

"I get agitated when people lie and make bold claims before me. You should know that 'God Descends from Heaven' isn't something ordinary people can play, and when someone claims they can play such a song to the end, it's only natural to doubt their claims."

"If I had known that you were the same person from that competition... I'm sorry." Ai Wan apologized to him again.

Yuan could tell that she was sincere in her apology, so he didn't hold any hard feelings for her.

"Don't worry about it. It was just a misunderstanding," he said to her.

"Thank you."

After a moment of silence, she asked him, "By the way, what are you doing at our sect? Do you intend on becoming a disciple?"

"No, I am only here because of Senior Song. I will be leaving soon."

"What a pity..." Ai Wan sighed.

"Pity?" Yuan lifted his eyebrows in a questioning manner.

"I heard from my Master that you are only playing the zither as a hobby and that you don't intend on becoming a zither expert. If I had your talents, I would definitely focus on becoming the best zither expert in the world."

"I mean it's not like I am not playing the zither at all. I just don't want it to be my main focus, as there are other things that I find more entertaining," said Yuan.

"It's your life, so I won't tell you how to live it. However, you will definitely disappoint many people with your decisions." Ai Wan shook her head.

"Anyways, I have one last thing to ask you... The zither you used to play just now... It's the Soul Ensnaring Zither, right?"

"Yes, it is."

Ai Wan went silent for a moment before speaking, "Do you want to try something?"

"What are you talking about?"

"The Zither Goddess used to be a disciple of our Heavenly Melody Academy. Did you know this?" Ai Wan then asked him.

"Yes, I do."

"Then did you know that her immortal cave hasn't been opened ever since she left?"

"Huh?" Yuan was puzzled yet intrigued at the same time.

"The Zither Goddess had her own immortal cave when she was still here, but it hasn't been opened since she left, but it's not because we don't want to open it— it's because it refuses to open for some reason."

"We believe that it's because the Zither Goddess had placed some sort of protection around her home, but she forgot to take it down when she left, so her immortal cave has remained unopened to this date."

"I was thinking that maybe you can open it with the Soul Ensnaring Zither."

"I can try." Yuan nodded.

"Okay, follow me." Ai Wan turned around and began walking.

Yuan quickly followed her.

"Why do you want to open the immortal cave?" Yuan couldn't help but ask her.

"I am curious— everyone is. We want to know what is inside the famous Zither Goddess's immortal cave. Maybe she has some heaven-defying zither techniques inside."

"Oh, I should also mention that while we cannot open it normally, we can definitely open it with force, but that would destroy the place, so nobody is willing to do such a thing."

"The Zither Goddess' immortal cave, huh? I would be lying if I say that I am not interested." Yuan said.

Sometime later, they arrived at the inner court, where all of the high-ranking sect elders and elite disciples lived.

"Disciple Ai Wan!"

A feminine voice suddenly called out to her shortly after they entered the inner court.

Ai Wan and Yuan turned around to see a pretty young lady approaching them in an aggressive manner.

"Disciple You, save your nonsense for another day. I am busy right now." Ai Wan said to her in an annoyed tone.

This young lady called Disciple You turned to look at Yuan before showing a grin on her face.

"Is that your new boyfriend? Wei Kang will be very upset once he learns of this."

"Why don't you mind your own business? In fact, shouldn't you be practicing for the upcoming prime disciple selection? Or are you so confident in your victory that you don't need to practice?" Ai Wan coldly sneered.

"I think we both— as well as every other disciple in the sect, know that I will pass the prime disciple selection and become the Sect Master's third disciple. And once I start studying under the Sect Master, I will quickly surpass you."

"I cannot wait." Ai Wan responded in a nonchalant manner.

"Hmph! Since I am a nobody in your eyes, you wouldn't mind going to the Lily Pavilion with me, right?"

"Again with the Lily Pavilion? I don't have the time to deal with you."

"Are you worried about embarrassing yourself in front of your boyfriend? If that's the case, I completely understand." Disciple You chuckled.

Ai Wan sneered, "First of all, he's not my boyfriend. And secondly, I already told you that I am busy right now. If you are so desperate to lose face in front of me, I will gladly meet you at the Lily Pavilion tomorrow."

"Now you've said it! If you don't show up tomorrow, I will make a laughingstock out of you! And you, mister boyfriend! Make sure you're there to see the look on your girlfriend's face when I completely destroy her tomorrow!" Disciple You said to them before walking away without waiting for any response, leaving Yuan speechless.

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Chapter 610 - Disappeared!

"I'm sorry about that... That was Disciple You, a new disciple that had been recruited by Master shortly after the zither competition, so she's a little arrogant. And for some reason, she's obsessed with surpassing me." Ai Wan said to Yuan afterward.

"You can also ignore what she said."

"What's this Lily Pavilion?" Yuan asked.

"It's a place where disciples go to battle each other with their instruments. The loser must jump into the cold water that surrounds the place. It's a very popular area for disciples who want to settle disputes."

"That does sound like a pretty fun place." Yuan smiled.

At least they don't have to injure each other, which is the biggest reason why people go there instead of the traditional challenge, where disciples fight each other with weapons.

"Anyways, let's continue to the Zither Goddess's immortal cave."

About half an hour later, they arrive at this secluded area where many immortal caves existed, and it sort of reminded Yuan of the immortal caves at the Jaded Garden but at a much larger scale.

"Which one belongs to the Zither Goddess?" Yuan asked as he looked around.

"Do you see that one with a closed entrance in the middle? That's the one." Ai Wan pointed at the immortal cave that had a couple of people standing outside of it.

"What are they doing?" Yuan asked when he saw the scene.

"They are all trying to open up the immortal cave without breaking the place," she said.

"You see people like that almost every day."

A few minutes later, they climbed the hill and approached the Zither Goddess's immortal cave.

"Damn it! This place really doesn't want to open up!"

"If it was so easy to open, it would've opened tens of thousands of years ago..."

"There must be some sort of secret to opening this door!"

"Hey, look over there! That's Prime Disciple Ai!"

"What's she doing here?"

The disciples stopped their investigation when they noticed Ai Wan's presence.

"Greetings, senior apprentice-sister."

They all greeted her when she was close enough.

"Hello," she nodded, acknowledging their greetings.

"What brings you to this place today, senior sister?" One of them asked her.

"I'm just looking around," she casually said before turning to look at Yuan, who was intensively staring at the immortal cave.

"Have you figured something out already?" she couldn't help but ask him, her voice sounding a little excited.

If anyone can open the immortal cave, it should be the person who managed to play the Zither Goddess' Soul Ensnaring Zither!

"I'm not sure... I don't see anything out of the ordinary about this place."
Yuan said.

"Why don't you try playing a song with the Soul Ensnaring Zither?" Ai Wan suddenly said.

"What song should I play?"

"Maybe something the Zither Goddess used to play?"

Yuan nodded and took a seat in front of the immortal cave before retrieving the Soul Ensnaring Zither.

"Senior apprentice-sister, who is this guy? I don't recognize him." One of the disciples there asked her.

"I don't know him either." Ai Wan calmly responded.

"Eh?"

The disciples looked at her with wide eyes, as they were not expecting such an answer. In fact, they believed that she was only joking with them.

Once Yuan was seated, he took a deep breath before playing Zither Goddess's Ethereal Arts before the immortal cave.

His performance immediately shocked the spectators.

"This guy... He's really in a different world in terms of talent...' Ai Wan sighed inwardly, and her disappointment in Yuan for not taking advantage of such talents grew stronger.

A few minutes later, Yuan stopped playing the zither when the song finished, but there was no response from the Zither Goddess' immortal cave.

"I-It's not opening..." Ai Wan mumbled in a dazed voice.

"Sorry that I couldn't be of any help," Yuan said to her afterward.

"No, don't worry about it. I should be apologizing for wasting your time."

"What a pity, though. I really wanted to see her immortal cave..." Yuan sighed as he placed his hand on the large boulder that hasn't budged for over 20,000 years.

It was at this moment the boulder suddenly began trembling.

"Eh?"

However, before Yuan could even react, his vision suddenly blacked out, almost like someone had turned off all the lights in a room.

"W-Where am I?" Yuan looked around, but even with his enhanced vision, he was unable to see anything.

Meanwhile, outside Zither Goddess' immortal cave, Ai Wan and the other disciples were shocked by what they had just witnessed.

"H-He disappeared!" One of the disciples there exclaimed after snapping out of his daze.

"Where did he go?! He was just standing there a second ago!"

Ai Wan quickly went to touch the boulder just like Yuan did, but nothing happened.

"This has never happened before!" She muttered in a voice of disbelief.

After standing there for a moment, Ai Wan turned around and began running away.

"W-Where are you going, senior apprentice-sister?!" The other disciples called out to her.

"I am going to get my Master!" she said.

And she continued, "You guys stay there just in case he returns!"

Sometime later, she arrived at the Sect Master's headquarters.

"Master! Are you here?!" Ai Wan rushed into the building while shouting.

"What happened?" Song Ling'er frowned when she saw how frantic Ai Wan was acting.

"D-Do you remember Yuan? That person who was at the zither competition? He disappeared!" She said, confusing Song Ling'er.

"What are you talking about? Start from the beginning, and slow down." Song Ling'er said.

Ai Wan took a few deep breaths before explaining to Song Ling'er the situation.

"He disappeared right in front of you after touching Zither Goddess' immortal cave? How is that possible?"

"It's true, Master! There are other disciples that witnessed it!"

"Let's go. We're going to the immortal caves." Song Ling'er said as she stood up.

Ai Wan then followed Song Ling'er back to the immortal caves... Ai Wan hoped that Yuan would have returned by then, but alas, he was still nowhere to be seen.

Chapter 611 - Freefall

After arriving at the immortal caves, Song Ling'er asked the disciples there for their story.

"That person touched the immortal cave and disappeared the next second!"

"It was so sudden! He hasn't returned since then!"

Song Ling'er frowned at the situation, and she began looking around the Zither Goddess' immortal cave, even touching the exact same spot that Yuan had touched, but nothing happened.

"Oh, I forgot to mention this, but he played a song with the Soul Ensnaring Zither before touching the immortal cave." Ai Wan suddenly said.

"Why didn't you tell me this first?!" Song Ling'er sighed.

"Do you know what kind of song he played?"

"No, I have never heard of such a song before."

"Can you replicate it?" Song Ling'er then asked.

Ai Wan didn't immediately respond. She closed her eyes and recalled Yuan's performance and tried to play his song inside her mind, but alas, she was unable to remember the song for some reason, almost like there was an otherworldly power preventing her from doing so.

"I cannot remember the song..." Ai Wan sighed after trying.

"What? You should be able to memorize a song after hearing it once. Was the song he played really that difficult?" Song Ling'er looked at Ai Wan

with a surprised face.

"Not difficult— it was complex, almost like it was a technique as well as a song. That's the best I can describe it." Ai Wan said.

"A song that is also a technique...? To think he's already reached that level..." Song Ling'er mumbled to herself.

And she continued a moment later, "Anyways, I don't think there is anything we can do but wait for him to return on his own."

"No way..." Ai Wan mumbled.

She couldn't help but blame herself for this situation, as she was the one who asked Yuan to open the Zither Goddess' immortal cave.

If she hadn't done such a thing, Yuan wouldn't have disappeared.

'If a heavenly genius like him is forever gone because of me...' Ai Wan could not imagine being responsible for the death of such a genius, so she silently prayed for his safety.

Meanwhile, somewhere in this universe, Yuan was surrounded by nothing but pure darkness.

"Hello?! Anyone there?!"

Yuan walked around in this darkness while shouting for the past few minutes but to no avail.

'I really hope this is the Zither Goddess' immortal cave and the reason it's so dark is because the lights are off...' Yuan sighed inwardly.

After walking aimlessly for about ten minutes, Yuan suddenly stopped, as he could see a thin line of light very far in the distance.

The moment he saw this, Yuan immediately began running towards this light.

However, this light was actually much further than it appeared.

Even though he had been running for many minutes, he doesn't seem to be getting any closer to the light.

About an hour later, he finally arrived before the light that was literally a bright pillar of light.

Yuan swallowed nervously, as he felt an incredibly strong beckoning coming from the pillar of light, almost as though it was daring him to approach it.

"As much as I don't want to get close to this light... It's probably my only way out of this void. As for where it will lead me— if it even leads to anywhere, I will have to find out myself."

Yuan closed his eyes and took a deep breath.

Once he was prepared, he began stepping towards this pillar of light, disappearing into it.

Yuan immediately began feeling dizzy after entering the pillar of light, but it wasn't an unfamiliar feeling, as he would often feel the same thing when he was being transported to someplace through teleportation.

'I am being teleported... but the question is where?' Yuan braced himself as he watched his surroundings blur.

The next moment, Yuan found himself in a very familiar scenery.

It was mostly blue, and it was surrounded by these fluffy white objects that would drift at a slow and smooth pace.

"Why am I in the sky again?!" Yuan exclaimed as his body began falling.

Fortunately, he was a Spirit Grandmaster, and he could fly.

Except that wasn't the case, as when he tried to fly, it didn't work at all, almost like the spiritual energy in the air didn't want to listen to him for

some reason.

"Is this how I will experience my first death in Cultivation Online?! This is so unfair!" Yuan cried out loud as he continued to freefall this seemingly endless sky.

A few more moments later, he could finally start seeing the ground.

It was at this moment that Yuan noticed the blue land that was directly beneath him, and he immediately released a sigh of relief.

'Thank the heavens that I am falling in water...'

However, before he even reached the water, he could see that there were a couple of people floating in this water.

And not wanting to land on them, he quickly shouted at them, "Get out of the way!"

These people were puzzled at first when they heard Yuan's voice, and they quickly began looking around in a frantic manner.

"I am above you!"

Yuan shouted again.

These people finally looked up, allowing Yuan to see their faces, and they were all extremely beautiful women.

However, before he could say anything else, his freefall had ended, and he fell into this somewhat deep pond.

"Phua!"

Yuan quickly tried to swim out of this pond, but since he has never learned how to swim before, he ended up struggling a bit.

If it were not for his superior strength that allowed him to move in the water without knowing how to swim, he would've never gotten out of the pond

and would've drowned to death sooner or later.

After getting out of the water, Yuan turned to face the six beautiful women that were still bathing inside the water, and all of them had a baffled look on their faces, looking like they were witnessing something that shouldn't be possible.

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Chapter 612 - Chased By Six Beauties

"H-Hello... Sorry for interrupting you all, but can you tell me where we are right now?" Yuan asked them in a somewhat dazed voice, as these women were truly breathtakingly beautiful.

However, these beautiful fairies remained silent as they continued to glare at him.

At first, they were dazed, then they slowly began to realize their situation.

Once they fully comprehended the situation, their dazed faces turned into frowns, and their gaze turned bloodthirsty.

Yuan swallowed nervously when he saw their unfriendly, even threatening gaze.

"Um..."

Unfortunately, before he could speak, one of them shouted, "It's a man! A man has defiled our paradise! Get him!"

Hearing their words, Yuan subconsciously turned around and began running for some reason.

Although he regretted this decision at first, he would quickly realize that it was actually the right choice.

"He's running! Chase after him!"

The six beauties immediately jumped out of the water, revealing their completely naked bodies, but Yuan was too occupied with running to care.

Once they were out of the water, these beauties quickly retrieved their robes to cover their bodies, but they didn't even bother dressing up properly before chasing after Yuan, looking like a group of ladies who just woke up late for work and are currently scrambling to get prepared.

'Heavens! They are fast!' Yuan cried inwardly when he saw them quickly closing in on him even though he started running many seconds ahead of them.

'And why can't I use Qi Manipulation in this place?'

Since he couldn't fly for some reason, he had to resort to using his movement technique.

After running for a few more moments, Yuan shouted, "Seniors! There must have been a misunderstanding! Why don't we all stop and talk about this like civil people?!"

As much as he wanted to stop and speak with them, he feared that these beauties might tear him to pieces the second he stopped.

"Civil?! Don't you dare talk about being civil when you are the one who invaded our territory! You're also the one who made a mistake by breaking the laws of this place!" One of the six beauties shouted back a second later.

"The punishment for breaking this law is the death sentence with no exceptions!"

Yuan was baffled by these ladies' words.

He'd broken the law? What kind of law did he break to deserve a death sentence?

"I swear! Whatever law I broke, it wasn't intentional!"

"Bullsh*t! You knew very well what you are doing!"

"Then can you at least tell me what kind of law I broke?!"

"How dare you still mess with us?! There's no way you don't know about the Fairy Paradise and its strict laws!"

Almost as though Yuan had angered them even further with his question, these beautiful ladies began chasing after him a little faster.

"Why is everyone in this world so unreasonable?! I just wanted to know what I did wrong!" Yuan cried out loud as he also quickened his steps with the movement technique.

"What kind of movement technique is this pervert using?! He's only a Spirit Grandmaster, yet we cannot catch him even after chasing him for so long!" One of the beauties said, admiring his movement technique a little.

"That's probably why he dared to enter the Fairy Paradise! If he thinks he can run forever, he's a fool!"

The six beauties then exchanged glances with each other before nodding their heads.

The next moment, Yuan could feel an obnoxious feeling coming from behind him, forcing him to turn around to see what was making him feel so uncomfortable, and to his shock, the six beauties had retrieved their weapons!

"Die, you pervert!"

The six beauties began unleashing a torrent of attacks on Yuan from behind.

Whoosh!

Bang!

Boom!

Yuan could feel his heart racing as he sensed the powerful spiritual energy within their attacks.

'This destructive power! They're all Spirit Kings?!' Yuan exclaimed inwardly when he realized their cultivation bases.

Why are there suddenly so many Spirit Kings in one place? Did he get transported to somewhere in the upper heavens again? But why would the Zither Goddess' immortal cave teleport him to this place?

"Dang it! Why are our attacks not hitting?! I really want to know what kind of movement technique he's using now!"

"Let's stop going easy on him and take him out for real!" One of them suddenly suggested.

"But won't that cause a commotion? We might get in trouble if we destroy the paradise anymore..."

"I'm sure the elders will understand! After all, we're trying to punish a man for entering our paradise! In fact, we'll probably get in more trouble if we let him escape!"

"Fine! Let's do it!"

However, before these beauties could release even more powerful attacks at Yuan, a cold voice suddenly resounded, "Halt!"

The beauties immediately stopped moving when they heard this voice, even giving up on chasing after Yuan.

Yuan, of course, didn't stop and continued to run away.

However, before he could move very far, a figure suddenly appeared before him like a ghost to block his path.

"I told you to halt, didn't I? Not only are you causing a commotion here, but you even dare to disobey me? You're a bold one even for men's standard."

This figure turned out to be another extremely beautiful woman, but her face was too cold.

"I—"

Yuan tried to open his mouth to speak, but before he could get any words out, the beautiful lady released a tyrannical pressure that instantly shut his mouth and even brought him to his knees.

'W-What cultivation is this?!'

Yuan was shocked by this intense pressure that surpassed all of his prior experiences.

If he had to take a guess, this woman was either a Spirit Emperor or even a Spirit Sovereign! She was not an existence he could defend against even with his heaven-defying talents!

"Oh? You're still conscious? Not bad for a mere Spirit Grandmaster." The cold woman spoke in a nonchalant voice after seeing that Yuan was still awake.

However, that didn't last long, as the cold woman increased the pressure a second later, instantly knocking Yuan unconscious.

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Chapter 613 - Imprisoned And Interrogated

After knocking Yuan unconscious, the cold woman turned to look at the other six beauties and said, "Six Spirit Kings cannot handle a mere Spirit Grandmaster— a little boy? You should all be ashamed of yourselves."

The six beauties lowered their heads in a shameful manner, their faces flushed with redness.

"We're sorry for being useless, Elder Xue."

"Quickly return to the sect and tell me everything that occurred just now." The cold woman called Elder Xue used her spiritual energy to pick up Yuan before flying away, disappearing into the distance in just a few moments.

The six beauties quickly followed Elder Xue's words and returned to the sect that was a hundred miles away from their location.

When Elder Xue returned to the sect first, she handed the still unconscious Yuan to one of the disciples there and said to her, "Lock him up and interrogate him for his identity when he wakes up."

"Yes, Elder Xue."

After Yuan was carried away, Elder Xue returned to her living quarters to wait for the six beauties to return.

Once they finally arrived, she said to them, "Tell me everything."

The six beauties that were standing beside each other began explaining the situation to Elder Xue.

"We went to the Bamboo Pond to wash ourselves, but shortly after we entered the water, we heard someone screaming, and it sounded like a man's voice."

"Once we realize where the sound was coming from, we all looked up, and to our surprise, a person was falling from the sky."

"We didn't know who this person was until we got a good look at him after he got out of the water, and he turned out to be an unknown man..."

"That's when we started chasing after him, but he had this weird movement technique that made it incredibly hard to catch him."

"So we started throwing weak attacks at him, hoping to delay him or stop him from running, but he was not only fast—he also displayed incredible agility by dodging all of our attacks with ease."

"Seeing that it had no effect on him, we decided to increase our strength..."

"...And that's when you arrived, Elder Xue."

"Hmmm..." Elder Xue listened to their whole story with her eyes closed, and they remained closed even after they finished.

The six beauties didn't dare to move until Elder Xue spoke to them, so they stood there in silence for many minutes until Elder Xue finally opened her eyes and spoke in a calm voice, "You can all leave. I will contact you if I need you."

"Excuse us, Elder Xue."

The beauties bowed to her before leaving the scene.

'Just where did this little boy come from? Falling from the sky? We're in the middle of Fairy Paradise! There's no way that a man could enter the Fairy Paradise and travel such a long distance without alerting anybody!' Elder Xue pondered to herself.

Meanwhile, somewhere inside a small prison cell, Yuan slowly opened his eyes after waking up.

"Ugh... Where am I...?" Yuan looked around, quickly realizing that he was inside a prison cell, and he was currently suspended in midair with chains restricting his movements.

"So you're finally awake?"

The disciple in charge of interrogating him said when she noticed that he was awake.

"Tell me who you are and how you managed to get inside the Fairy Paradise. Although that won't spare you from a death sentence, you won't feel any pain if you make it easy for the both of us."

Yuan frowned and said, "I don't know how I got to this place. I seem to have been teleported here by accident."

"Hah? And you expect me to believe such a blatant lie?" The disciple shook her head.

"You know what? Since I am a very generous individual, I will give you a second chance. If not..."

The disciple suddenly retrieved a whip that appeared to be made out of steel and cracked it beside her.

Pap!

The stone floor broke into many pieces when it was struck by the whip.

Yuan swallowed nervously when he saw the steel whip.

'I don't want to hurt her, but I can't just let her torture me...' Yuan sighed inwardly.

It was at this moment that he noticed the shiny ring sitting on a table beside the disciple.

"T-That's my storage ring!" He subconsciously exclaimed out loud.

The disciple turned to look at the Dragon Spatial Ring and smiled, "Oh? So the answer to your identity is inside this spatial ring, huh? Unfortunately, I do not have the power to open it, but once I hand it to an elder..."

Of course, there was nothing about his identity inside the spatial ring. However, there was something even more important— the Dragon Ancestor's Blood Essence! If these people learn of the blood essence, they will definitely steal it from him!

'Damn it! I knew I should have given it to Xiao Hua for safekeeping!' Yuan cursed inwardly.

'Should I just break out of this place? They don't know about my Soul Weapons... However, I won't be able to run away from that cold woman if she shows up again... What can I do in this situation?'

While Yuan pondered, the disciple contacted Elder Xue using a communication jade slip, "Elder Xue, I have not managed to get his identity, but I think the answer lies within his storage ring. I believe it would be quicker to just break open his storage ring and find the answers ourselves."

"Okay, I will be there. Give me a few minutes."

After putting away the communication jade slip, the woman looked at Yuan and said, "Good news. We'll know your identity really soon."

Yuan ignored her and continued to ponder for a way out of this predicament.

Sometime later, Elder Xue arrived at the prison cell to look at Yuan's storage ring.

"T-This is..."

However, to the disciple's surprise, Elder Xue appeared to be spooked by the spatial ring.

After a long moment of silence, Elder Xue turned to look at Yuan with a complicated expression on her face.

"I will be back later! Don't touch him or this spatial ring until I return!" Elder Xue said to the disciple before disappearing from the place without even touching the spatial ring once, leaving her speechless.

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Chapter 614 - Dragon Spatial Ring

'What happened?' Yuan wondered to himself as he watched Elder Xue leave the scene in a hurry.

The disciple was also dumbfounded by the turn of events, and she turned to look at Yuan with a profound expression on her face.

'Just who is this guy?' she wondered to herself.

Meanwhile, after leaving the prison area, Elder Xue went to summon other sect elders.

About half an hour later, Elder Xue sat in a medium-sized room with a dozen other figures, all females.

"What happened, Sister Xue?" One of them asked after everyone was seated.

"We have a problem," she responded with a deep frown on her face.

The atmosphere there immediately became serious when the others saw Elder Xue's expression, as she's rarely this solemn.

"First of all, a man had entered the Fairy Paradise," she continued after a moment of silence.

"What?! A man?! How dare this savage beast invade our sacred territory! Doesn't he know that men are not allowed in the Fairy Paradise, and breaking this rule is punishable with the death sentence?!"

"There are always people who want to try their luck. This is the 3rd man to invade our territory in the last 10 years."

"It's only a man, right? Why are you so serious about it, Sister Xue? Just kill him and toss his body back where it belongs like we always do."
Another one said.

Elder Xue shook her head and said, "That's the problem. This person isn't just an ordinary man. He has a Dragon Spatial Ring with him..."

"Wait... What? A Dragon Spatial Ring?"

Elder Xue watched as everyone in the room widened their eyes after they realized the situation.

"Dragon Spatial Ring... You're telling me this man that invaded our territory is from the Royal Dragon Family?"

"Why would someone from the Royal Dragon Family invade our territory? They should know very well to not do such a thing, as that could potentially start a war."

"How do we know if he's true royalty? He could have stolen that ring for all we know."

"If he's really from the Royal Dragon Family, we cannot kill him so easily."

"Should we speak with the Sect Master about this?"

"Did you forget? The Sect Master is currently away to help the Fairy Empress."

"How troublesome..."

"Sister Xue, what do you think we should do in this situation?"

The people there all turned to look at Elder Xue, who was the most senior in the room.

Elder Xue closed her eyes to ponder.

After a moment of silence, she spoke, "We should verify his identity first."

"How are we going to do that? What if he lies? We will have no way to verify it unless we go to the Royal Dragon Family."

"Then bring someone from the Royal Dragon Family here to verify his identity just in case. Tell them about the situation. I'm sure they'll understand and cooperate. After all, this could potentially lead to another war."

"I will go to the Royal Dragon Family." Someone there immediately volunteered.

"Okay."

"I will handle interrogating that man." Elder Xue said.

Sometime later, Elder Xue ended the meeting and returned to the prison cell.

"Bring him down." Elder Xue said to the disciple there.

"Y-Yes!"

While the disciple worked on bringing Yuan back down, Elder Xue spoke to him, "This does not mean you're free. If you do anything funny, I will kill you. If you try to run, I will kill you. Do you understand?"

Yuan silently nodded his head.

Once he was released from the chains, Elder Xue pointed to the Dragon Spatial Ring and said, "Open it and dump everything out."

Yuan immediately hesitated for obvious reasons.

"Either you do it by yourself or I kill you and open it myself. Don't be mistaken. I can easily force open the Spatial Ring with my cultivation base. I am merely giving you a chance to show your sincerity." Elder Xue said to him.

Of course, she lied about killing him to scare him. However, she was telling the truth about opening the spatial ring by herself.

Although only the owners can open their spatial rings in normal circumstances, a cultivator with a strong enough cultivation base can forcefully open spatial rings and pouches at the cost of destroying the spatial ring.

"Alright, I will open it," Yuan said, as he was left with no other choice.

Elder Xue grabbed the Dragon Spatial Ring and tossed it to Yuan.

The moment Yuan had the Dragon Spatial Ring in his grasp, he immediately tried to log off the game.

Even if he doesn't really go anywhere and has to return to this place when he logs back into the game, at least he can delay this situation to a certain extent. Furthermore, it could confuse these people.

However, a notification popped up when Yuan tried to log off, leaving him speechless.

[You cannot log off during a hostile situation]

'I cannot log off?!'

This is the second time that he has encountered this kind of situation. The first time was when he tried to log off right before the Demon Lord denoted itself, but since he was in combat, it didn't let him log off, forcing him to take the explosion head-on.

"Wait are you waiting for? If you're planning something..." Elder Xue narrowed her gaze at Yuan when he stood there without moving for longer than she was comfortable with.

'Haaa... Looks like I really cannot escape this situation...' Yuan sighed inwardly.

He then opened the Dragon Spatial Ring and dumped everything out, feeling as though he was being robbed at gunpoint.

The next moment, a couple of items fell out.

The Soul Ensnaring Zither, Golden Dragon Robe, the Demon Lord's Demon Core, cultivation techniques, live-saving treasures, the Seven Colored Herb, and last but not least, the Dragon Ancestor's Blood Essence.

Elder Xue and the disciple stared with wide eyes as all of these treasures lay on the floor before them. Even though they didn't recognize half of these treasures, they could tell their value by its unfathomable aura.

'This guy... Just who is this man?!' Elder Xue cried inwardly.

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Chapter 615 - Royal Dragon Family

'A bottle that seems to contain some sort of blood essence, life-saving treasures, a demon core, and even the Seven Colored Herb?! This man is loaded with treasures!' The disciple cried inwardly when she saw the treasures on the floor, feeling a strong urge to take them for herself.

Of course, with Elder Xue standing right beside her, she didn't dare to actually act upon her desires.

As for Elder Xue, she couldn't care less about the treasures, and the only thing in her sights right now was the Golden Dragon Robe.

'He not only has a Dragon Spatial Ring, but he also has a Golden Dragon Robe... I will be damned if he's not part of the Royal Dragon Family!' Elder Xue sighed inwardly.

After seeing the Golden Dragon Robe, Elder Xue was almost convinced that Yuan belonged to the Royal Dragon Family. The only thing that didn't make sense was Yuan's behavior, as he was being oddly quiet and obedient even in such a situation.

If he was actually from the Royal Dragon Family, he would've long revealed his identity so that they couldn't just kill him.

'Maybe he has a reason that forbids him from revealing his identity?' Elder Xue wondered to herself.

"You can put your stuff back inside the storage ring." Elder Xue said to him a moment later.

'Eh?'

Although Yuan was surprised by her words, he didn't question it and immediately stored his treasures back into the Dragon Spatial Ring.

Elder Xue then asked him, "Who are you? Why did you come to the Fairy Paradise? Men are forbidden from stepping inside this land regardless of your status and reason."

'Men are not allowed here? This explains why I am being treated like this...' Yuan sighed inwardly as he finally realized the situation.

"My name is Yuan, and like I'd said multiple times by now— I didn't come here by choice. I was teleported here by accident after touching the Zither Goddess' immortal cave, and I have never even heard of a Fairy Paradise until today."

"Zither Goddess?" Elder Xue raised her eyebrows upon hearing this name, but it didn't seem like she knew of the Zither Goddess.

"Anyways, you'll be staying here until we can verify your identity. If you try to escape... You'll know what will happen to you, right?" Elder Xue then said to him.

"Yes, I know..." Yuan nodded.

Elder Xue turned to look at the disciple and said, "Continue watching over him. If he tries to leave or does anything funny, put him back in the chains."

"I-I understand." The disciple nodded, and she noticed that Elder Xue didn't specifically tell her to 'kill him', which would be the normal command.

'This man must have a special status... This is the first time that a man has been allowed to enter the Fairy Paradise without getting executed immediately...' The disciple thought to herself.

After Elder Xue left the scene, Yuan tried to log off the game, but to his surprise, he was still unable to leave due to still being in a hostile situation.

'Does this mean I am stuck inside this game until they no longer see me as a threat? How long is that going to take?' Yuan sighed inwardly.

Meanwhile, somewhere in this world, an hour after leaving, one of the sect elders from the Fairy Paradise arrived at the Royal Dragon Family's residence with the help of a powerful flying treasure.

"Halt! State your identity and your purpose for visiting the Royal Family!"

The guards at the residence stopped this sect elder, and they were all emitting a unique aura that only belonged to dragons.

"I am Elder Zou from the Fairy Paradise, and we believe that a man from the Royal Dragon Family has broken our law by entering our territory, so I am here to seek for an explanation from the Royal Family!"

"What? Someone from our family entered the Fairy Paradise? That's impossible! Everybody is aware of the law! And we have no reason to enter the Fairy Paradise!" The guards immediately refused to believe that someone from their family would do such a thing.

"I don't care what you have to say! That man who intruded our place had a Dragon Spatial Ring with him, and only the Royal Dragon Family would have such a thing! Even if he's not part of the Royal Family, he's definitely connected to you guys one way or another!" Elder Zou said.

And she continued, "If you're telling me that he doesn't belong to the Royal Dragon Family then we will execute him right now!"

The guards immediately began sweating after hearing such words.

What if someone from the Royal Dragon Family had really snuck inside the Fairy Paradise? That would be disastrous if true!

"P-Please wait a moment. I will notify the Dragon King of the situation right now." One of the guards said to her before entering the massive palace behind them.

"Your Majesty! We have an emergency!" The guard rushed to the Dragon King's room and knocked on it.

"What happened?" The door opened a moment later, and a handsome middle-aged man with two bright golden horns on his head appeared before the guard.

"Elder Zou from the Fairy Paradise is here, and she claims that someone from the Royal Family had intruded their territory." The guard explained the situation to the Dragon King.

"What? Someone from my family snuck inside the Fairy Paradise? How is that possible? Who did it?!" The Dragon King was immediately enraged to hear this news, but he was also in disbelief, as he couldn't imagine somebody from his family would do such an idiotic thing.

"She didn't give us any names. In fact, she only 'believes' it was someone from our family because that person has a Dragon Spatial Ring," said the guard.

"Bring her inside! I want to speak with her personally!" The Dragon King commanded.

"Yes! Please excuse this subject!" The guard bowed to the Dragon King before returning to Elder Zou and the others.

"The Dragon King wishes to speak with you... Please follow me."

Chapter 616 - Dragon Emperor

"Welcome, Elder Zou, to my royal estate. You claim that someone from my Royal Family had entered the Fairy Paradise, is that correct?" The Dragon King asked Elder Zou when she arrived before him.

"And before you answer my question, you should know that I don't respond to false claims nicely."

Elder Zou coldly sneered and said, "And you should know that the Fairy Paradise doesn't respond well to rule breakers! A man with a Dragon Spatial Ring had invaded our territory, and I am here to verify whether he belongs to your family or not!"

"If he doesn't belong to your family, we will immediately execute him! However, if he does turn out to belong to the royal family, our Fairy Paradise will demand an explanation and compensation!"

The Dragon King then spoke, "While it is true that only the Royal Family should have a Dragon Spatial Ring, it is also possible for others to obtain the ring through other means. It's rare for this to happen, but it's not impossible."

The Dragon King then turned to look at the guard standing beside him and said, "What's the result?"

"I have managed to contact all of the men in the Royal Dragon Family and confirm that none of them have entered the Fairy Paradise," said the guard.

Elder Zou frowned upon hearing the guard's words. If that was true, that would mean the man with the Dragon Spatial Ring doesn't belong to the Royal Dragon Family.

"As you heard just now, Elder Zou, we have accountability for all men in the family, so it is not possible for that intruder to belong to our royal family!"

"That's all I need to hear. Then I will let the others know so that they can go ahead and continue with the execution," said Elder Zou as she retrieved a communication jade slip.

The Dragon King then added, "After you take care of that man, if you don't mind, can you return the Dragon Spatial Ring to us to prevent future misunderstandings? We'll compensate you for the effort."

"Of course." Elder Zou nodded.

A moment later, Elder Xue picked up the communication.

"Sister Xue, I have just spoken with the Dragon King. The man who invaded our territory doesn't belong to the Royal Dragon Family, so we can go ahead and kill him."

However, to Elder Zou's surprise, Elder Xue requested to speak with the Dragon King.

"Let me speak with the Dragon King."

Elder Zou then handed the communicated jade slip to the Dragon King, "Elder Xue would like to speak with you."

The Dragon King didn't think much of it and accepted the communicated jade slip.

"What do you want, Elder Xue?"

"Dragon King, are you absolutely certain that the intruder doesn't belong to the Royal Dragon Family?" Elder Xue asked him in a solemn voice.

"I have already gotten accountability for all men in my family and none of them is even near the Fairy Paradise! I am one hundred percent certain that

the intruder does not belong to my royal family! Or are you trying to tell me that I am wrong?"

After a moment of silence, Elder Xue spoke, "Then can you explain to me why this person has a Golden Dragon Robe?"

"WHAT?!"

The Dragon King immediately stood up and exclaimed in a shocked voice, dumbfounding the guard and Elder Zou there.

"Impossible! That is not possible! Although a Dragon Spatial Ring could've accidentally gotten into the hands of a stranger, as it has happened a couple of times before, the Golden Dragon Robe is an entirely different story with no such incidents!" The Dragon King quickly refuted.

And he continued, "The Golden Dragon Robe can only be given to someone that will become a future Dragon Emperor! Our family doesn't even have a Dragon Emperor! How can we possibly lose a Golden Dragon Robe when we don't even have one?!"

In the world of dragon royalty, there are different ranks of authority and power.

From the lowest to the highest— Dragon Prince/Princess, Dragon Lord, Dragon King, Dragon Emperor, Dragon God, and last but not least, Dragon Ancestor.

The Royal Dragon Family Yuan met in the Ancient Dragon City had Dragon Emperors, but in this world, Dragon King was the highest rank.

"I don't believe it! I will send someone there to verify his identity!" The Dragon King spoke after a long moment of silence.

He then turned to look at the guard and said, "Bring Shen Shi here as soon as possible!"

"Yes!"

"What is happening?" Elder Zou asked him.

The Dragon King looked at her and said, "That's what I would like to know. If this intruder truly has a Golden Dragon Robe, you must not harm him under any circumstances!"

"Why? What's so special about this Golden Dragon Robe?" Elder Zou frowned.

"The Golden Dragon Robe represents a Dragon Emperor. There are many ranks in the Royal Dragon Family, and a Dragon Emperor is up there. If you kill a Dragon Emperor, you won't just offend the Royal Dragon Family — you'll be hunted by them."

"The Fairy Paradise might have the Fairy Empress and that person, but you won't be able to defend against the whole Royal Dragon Family all over the Nine Heavens. Furthermore, you'll only see Dragon Emperors above the Sixth Heaven, and we're currently in the Fifth Heaven."

Elder Zou frowned and said, "So you're telling me this invader came from the upper heavens?"

"No, this is only a speculation. However, if it turns out that he really has a Golden Dragon Robe... Things will get a little complicated for the Fairy Paradise and my royal family." The Dragon King sighed.

Sometime later, a beautiful young lady with a single golden horn on the side of her head appeared before the Dragon King.

"I have arrived, father. Why have you summoned me?"

"Shen Shi, you are to follow Elder Zou here to the Fairy Paradise... There is a person there with the Golden Dragon Robe, and I want you to verify his identity," said the Dragon King, instantly dumbfounding her.

Chapter 617 - Release Him Immediately!

"D-Did you just say the Golden Dragon Robe, father?" Shen Shi asked him with a dumbfounded look on her face.

"Yes, I did." The Dragon King nodded with a solemn face.

"We don't have any Dragon Emperors in this world, so does this mean that someone from the upper heavens came down here? But why the Fairy Paradise?" Shen Shi then asked.

"I am sending you there to answer that question. Hurry up and get moving. If he's really a Dragon Emperor, we don't want anything to happen to him. If he's real, you should know what to do."

"I understand."

Shen Shi then followed Elder Zou back to the Fairy Paradise using some sort of special talisman that teleported them there within seconds.

Meanwhile, back at the Fairy Paradise, Yuan was sitting in the corner of the prison cell while silently pondering to himself if there was anything else he could do to get out of this situation.

'I just wanted to look at the Zither Goddess's immortal cave...' He sighed inwardly.

Eventually, Elder Xue returned to the prison and said to him, "Take out your Golden Dragon Robe. I need to verify something."

Yuan had no choice but to hand over his Golden Dragon Robe to her.

'At least she didn't ask for the blood essence...' He thought to himself as he handed her the Golden Dragon Robe.

Once she had the robe, Elder Xue left the scene and went to another place, where Shen Shi and the other sect elders were waiting.

"Here is the Golden Dragon Robe. Please verify it." Elder Xue handed the robe to Shen Shi.

"T-This is..."

Shen Shi was visibly shaken when she touched the Golden Dragon Robe.

"This is real... My blood is reacting to it..."

She then looked at Elder Xue and spoke with a frown on her face, "You need to release that person immediately!"

"Unfortunately, that is not possible, as he'd violated our Fairy Paradise's law, and without the Fairy Empress's approval, we cannot let him go." One of the elders there said.

"Screw the rules! This is a Dragon Emperor we're talking about! Even if he's not from our Royal Dragon Family, we have a responsibility to protect him! If anything happens to him, we'll be the least of your worries!"

"You do not belong to a royal family, so I don't blame you for being ignorant, but a Dragon Emperor is not someone you can offend! A single Dragon Emperor can remove my entire family with a single command, much less your Fairy Paradise!"

The elders there were left speechless by Shen Shi's words. They have never encountered a Dragon Emperor before, so they didn't know the severity of their situation.

"We'll release the man, but this doesn't mean he can leave." Elder Xue suddenly said.

And she continued, "Before we can fully release him, we'll need to speak with the Fairy Empress."

"Hmph! I doubt the Fairy Empress will be willing to go to war with the Royal Dragon Family for a single man! And I will be staying here until he is free!" Shen Shi said.

"Do as you please." Elder Xue said before leaving the place and returning to the prison cell that held Yuan.

Of course, Shen Shi followed her, as she wanted to meet this mysterious Dragon Emperor for herself.

'H-He's the Dragon Emperor? He's so young! Not to mention his lacking cultivation base! Is he really a Dragon Emperor?'

Shen Shi's eyes widened with surprise when she saw Yuan. This is her first time meeting a Dragon Emperor, so she wasn't sure what to expect, but she definitely wasn't expecting to see a handsome young man like Yuan.

"Here's your robe. We'll be releasing you for now, but that doesn't mean you're completely free to go, as we still have to speak with the Fairy Empress. In the meantime, you'll be staying in a designated area." Elder Xue said to Yuan as she returned the Golden Dragon Robe to him.

When Yuan left the prison cell, Shen Shi approached him with a friendly smile on her face.

"Hello, senior. I am Shen Shi of the Royal Dragon Family, and I will do my best to sort things out for you. Until then, I will be staying with you. If you need anything, just let me know."

'The Royal Dragon Family...?' Yuan immediately recalled the royal family from the Ancient Dragon City.

"My name is Yuan," he then said.

"Follow me, I will lead you to your living quarters for now." Elder Xue said to them.

Sometime later, they arrived in this secluded area that had a single house but a large courtyard.

"You are not allowed to leave this area until we give you the permission. If you try to escape, we will kill you even if you're a Dragon Emperor." Elder Xue said to him.

'What? Dragon Emperor?' Yuan raised his eyebrows when he heard her words.

Since when did he become a Dragon Emperor? This made him recall how the dragons in the Ancient Dragon City mistook him as someone from the royal family.

'Now that I think about it, this situation is really similar to when I first arrived in the Ancient Dragon City.' Yuan smiled bitterly when he realized this.

Elder Xue left the scene shortly after, but there were many guards that surrounded this area.

"Let's go inside to talk, shall we?" Shen Shi said to him.

"Okay."

Once they entered the building, they both sat down in front of each other.

"I'm sure you have many questions, but allow me to ask you a few questions first." Shen Shi started the conversation.

And she continued, "First and foremost... Are you really a Dragon Emperor — or from the Royal Dragon Family for that matter? Although you have the Dragon Spatial Ring and even the Golden Dragon Robe, I am still not entirely convinced that you're one."

Yuan didn't immediately respond to her question and took his time pondering how he should respond.

Chapter 618 - Can I See Your Horns?

'Should I tell her the truth? But if they learn that I am not from the royal family... No, I should pretend to be a Dragon Emperor for my own safety...'

After pondering for a moment, Yuan has decided to act as though he was from the Royal Dragon Family, as he would be killed if he wasn't.

"That's right, I am indeed from the Royal Dragon Family," he said to Shen Shi in a calm voice.

Of course, Shen Shi wasn't completely convinced by his words, as there are several questionable points about his claims.

First, why has he kept his identity a secret until now? If he'd revealed his identity earlier, he wouldn't have been treated so roughly.

Secondly, he didn't have concrete proof that he was from a royal family, and they won't be able to verify his identity until they bring him back to their family, where the tools to verify his identity is available.

The Dragon Spatial Ring and the Golden Dragon Robe may convince a lot of people, but it won't fool the real royal family.

"Can you prove it?" Shen Shi suddenly asked him, still with a smile on her face.

And she continued, "Don't misunderstand my intentions, Senior Yuan, but I have never seen a Dragon Emperor before, and I want to know for sure so that you can receive my family's full support."

"I don't blame you for being skeptical. Alright, I will prove it." Yuan said to her before closing his eyes.

After a moment of silence, he opened his eyes and activated Dragon Gaze, causing his eyes to glow golden and emit an intimidating aura.

"?!?!"

When Shen Shi experienced Yuan's Dragon Gaze, her body trembled from excitement and fear at the same time even though her cultivation base was far higher than Yuan's.

'It's really the Dragon's Gaze! And it's so much more powerful than mine! He's the real deal! A real Dragon Emperor!' Shen Shi clenched her fists and jaws just to keep her emotions in control, but her heart was pounding with excitement.

After experiencing Yuan's powerful Dragon's Gaze, Shen Shi stood up before kneeling in front of him, "Please forgive this Junior for doubting the Senior's identity. Our Shen Royal Family will do everything in our power to protect Senior even if it means war against the Fairy Paradise."

"War? Calm down. I do not wish for any wars because of me." Yuan quickly shook his head.

"Then if there's anything this Junior can do to help you..."

Yuan nodded and said, "I'd like some information about this place. You see, I accidentally got transported to this place, so I am a little clueless at this moment."

"S-So that's what happened..." Shen Shi mumbled in a low voice. This explained why he was a Dragon Emperor and they didn't recognize him! To think that he'd been transported here by accident!

"Although such incidents are rare, it's not unprecedented. Since you're a Dragon Emperor, I assume that you came from the upper heavens?"

"S-Something like that." Yuan quickly nodded.

If she knew that he came from the Lower Heavens, that would instantly give away his identity.

"Anyway, allow me to tell you about our humble world, Senior."

"You can sit down." Yuan suddenly said to her, who was still kneeling on the floor.

"Thank you, Senior."

After clearing her throat, she began to speak, "We are currently inside the Fairy Paradise within the Fifth Heaven."

"Fifth Heaven?!" Yuan was shocked to learn this information.

To think he'd traveled four entire realms! Just what kind of secret is the Zither Goddess hiding? Why would her immortal caves do something like this?

"The Fairy Paradise is a unique place in the Fifth Heaven that forbids men from entering this land regardless of their status. There are many sects and families within the Fairy Paradise, and this particular sect is called the Fleeting Fairy Sect."

"Looks like I have fallen into a troublesome place..." Yuan sighed.

"Don't worry, Senior Yuan. Our Royal Dragon Family will guarantee your safety. Although I said that there is no exception, I highly doubt the Fairy Empress is willing to go to war with the Royal Dragon Family over an accident like this. Furthermore, it was not as though you came to this place with malicious intentions."

"Fairy Empress... Is she like the ruler of the Fairy Paradise?" Yuan asked.

"Yes, that's right. She's the number one expert in this world, hence why not many people dare to intrude on this land."

"You'll most likely have to meet her later to deal with the situation."

"I look forward to it." Yuan said with a bittersweet smile.

After talking for some time, Yuan noticed that Shen Shi was actually a little bit fidgety for some reason, so he decided to ask her, "Are you okay?"

"Y-Yes!" Shen Shi responded in a nervous tone.

"If you have something to say, go ahead and say it." Yuan urged.

Shen Shi stared at him for a moment before nodding, "T-Then if you don't mind... Senior Yuan, can I see your horns? I want to see what a Dragon Emperor's horn looks like..."

"My... horns?" Yuan was left speechless by her innocent question that was sparked by her curiosity.

After all, a dragon's horn is incredibly important to them.

"S-Sorry, but due to circumstances, I cannot show you my horns." Yuan politely declined.

"Is that so... It's fine, Senior Yuan. You don't need to apologize. It was rude of me to ask you in the first place." Shen Shi said with a smile on her face, but the disappointment in her eyes wasn't hidden well enough.

Although some dragons prefer having their horns out all the time like Shen Shi and her family, some dragons don't want to show their horns for many different reasons.

'Now that I think about it, the dragons at the Ancient Dragon City didn't show their horns. I wonder if there's a specific reason...' Yuan wondered to himself.

Chapter 619 - Dont Resist

Chapter 619 - Don't Resist

After talking to each other for a few minutes, Shen Shi stood up and said, "Please excuse me for a bit, Senior Yuan. I still need to notify my father of the circumstances so that he can prepare accordingly. He's probably shaking in anxiety right now from waiting."

"Go ahead. Take your time." Yuan nodded.

Shen Shi then left the scene and went outside to contact her father using a communication jade slip.

"Shen Shi?! What is the news?! Is this person really a Dragon Emperor?!" Her father immediately began questioning her in an anxious manner.

"Calm down, father. You'll need all of your breath for this..." Shen Shi said to him.

And she continued, "It's true, this person is the real deal— a real Dragon Emperor!"

The Dragon King stared at the communication jade slip with a look of disbelief on his face.

A real Dragon Emperor? If this is true, they must protect him at all cost!

"Tell me everything!" The Dragon King said.

"Yes!"

Shen Shi proceeded to explain everything she heard from Yuan to her father.

"He accidentally arrived in the Fairy Paradise and actually belongs to the upper heaven? No wonder why he's already a Dragon Emperor despite being only a Spirit Grandmaster!"

Shen Shi's voice then resounded, "Father, we must protect him at all cost! Now that we are aware of his presence, if anything happens to him, our family will be held responsible!"

"You don't have to tell me the obvious! We'll protect him even if we have to go to war with the Fairy Paradise!" The Dragon King declared.

"Anyways, I will leave the Dragon Emperor in your care while I speak with the Fairy Empress, Shen Shi. If he takes a liking to you, it will greatly benefit our family!"

"E-Eh? Does this mean you want me to..."

"No! Do not try to seduce him, as that could have the opposite effect! However, if he makes any advances on you, don't resist or refuse him! If you join a Dragon Emperor's family, our future bloodline will become purer and more powerful!"

"I understand, father." Shen Shi acknowledged before putting away the communication jade slip.

"Haaaa..." She released a deep sigh before returning to the building.

However, to her surprise, Yuan had completely disappeared from the place like a ghost.

But when she started questioning it, something altered her thoughts, making her forget about Yuan temporarily.

As for Yuan, he'd tried logging off the game after she left, and it was a success.

"Are you done playing already, Brother Yuan?" Chu Liuxiang, who had been lying beside him the entire time, asked him when he logged off.

"Yes. Too much has happened today, and I need some time to rest."

"What happened? I will listen if you tell me," she said.

Yuan nodded and proceeded to recall his experience.

Meanwhile, somewhere in the Fairy Paradise.

"Fairy Empress, something big has occurred in our land." An extraordinarily beautiful woman spoke as she approached the Fairy Empress, who was sitting on a large throne, silently cultivating.

"What happened?" The Fairy Empress opened her eyes, revealing her exquisite emerald eyes.

"A man had entered our Fairy Paradise—"

"A man? And here I thought it was something serious. Just execute him like we always do," said the Fairy Empress, interrupting the other woman.

"Unfortunately, this man is a little special, so we cannot just kill him..."

"Special? I don't care if he's the king of multiple continents. If they disrespect my rules, they will pay the price—"

"Fairy Empress, this man is a Dragon Emperor from the Royal Dragon Family." The woman interrupted.

"What did you just say?" The Fairy Empress' eyes widened with disbelief.

"According to my disciples at the sect, a man had suddenly appeared in the Fairy Paradise, and this man turned out to be a Dragon Emperor," said the woman who was the sect master of the Fleeting Fairy Sect.

However, the Fairy Empress doubted this information, "A Dragon Emperor, you say? That is not possible. They should only exist in the Six Heaven and above. Why would a Dragon Emperor appear here?"

"It's true, Fairy Empress. My disciples even went to the Royal Dragon Family to get someone to verify his identity. The Dragon King is now demanding we release this man."

The Fairy Empress turned silent after hearing such news.

'If this man is really a Dragon Emperor, we cannot kill him, or we will risk offending the entire Royal Family Dragon. Although I can handle the royal families in this world, if the other royal families from the upper heaven start causing trouble as well, it would be disastrous for us...'

'Unlike a Dragon King, a Dragon Emperor is highly regarded in the Royal Dragon Family, so they will definitely protect him even if it will start a war.'

After many moments of silence, the Fairy Empress spoke, "What else do we know about this Dragon Emperor?"

The sect master then recalled everything her disciples told her to the Fairy Empress.

"Interesting... I want to speak with this mysterious Dragon Emperor who appeared out of thin air."

"When do you wish to see him? I will let my disciples arrange it."

"I am a little busy now so I will see him in three days. He may be a Dragon Emperor, but he still violated my rules, so he'll have to wait a little."

"I understand. Please excuse me while I relay this information to my disciples."

The following day, Yuan returned to Cultivation Online to find Shen Shi quietly sitting on the couch.

"I apologize for disappearing so suddenly yesterday without telling you." Yuan said to her.

However, to his surprise, Shen Shi didn't appear to care about it. In fact, she was oddly dismissive about it, not even bothering to ask any questions.

'If Cultivation Online is real and these people are not actual NPCs, why don't they question us, players, when we suddenly disappear? Is something preventing her from caring?' Yuan wondered to himself as he silently stared at Shen Shi.

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Chapter 620 - Meeting The Fairy Empress

'Let's test this out...' Yuan thought to himself.

The next second, he logged off the game right in front of Shen Shi.

"Eh? Where did he go...?" Shen Shi was baffled by Yuan's sudden disappearance.

However, when she tried to think any further about the situation, she suddenly stopped caring for some reason.

A moment later, Yuan reappeared before her.

"Senior?" Shen Shi looked at him weirdly.

"What do you think of that?" Yuan suddenly asked her.

"Think of what, Senior?" Shen Shi tilted her head in a puzzled manner.

"The way I disappeared and reappeared like a ghost. What do you think about it?"

"You disappeared? When?" Shen Shi asked, dumbfounding Yuan.

"Just now? Look, I will even do it again."

Yuan proceeded to log off and back in for a second time in front of her.

However, Shen Shi remained nonchalant about it.

"You really don't see anything wrong with me disappearing and reappearing so randomly?" Yuan asked her.

"But Senior, you have been standing there this entire time... Are you playing a joke on me? I'm sorry, but I don't understand it..." Shen Shi shook her head.

"Sorry, forget about it." Yuan gave up on asking Shen Shi.

Sometime later, Yuan went outside to the backyard to cultivate.

'I didn't notice this before because of my situation, but the spiritual energy in this place is very thick... I should take advantage of this and cultivate.'

Yuan then started his cultivation, quickly absorbing the spiritual energy around him.

Shen Shi watched him cultivate out of curiosity, and to her absolute shock, Yuan was cultivating so fast that a small vortex was created around him, and it swallowed the surrounding spiritual energy like a beast!

'What ridiculous cultivation talents! As expected of a Dragon Emperor from the upper heavens!' Shen Shi cried inwardly as she continued to watch over him.

Sometime later, Elder Xue showed up at their place to let them know the Fairy Empress's response.

"I will take you to meet with the Fairy Empress in three days." Elder Xue said to them.

"I understand." Yuan nodded.

Once Elder Xue left the scene, Yuan returned to cultivating for the remainder of the day.

"I will see you tomorrow." Yuan said to her before logging off.

"Please wait a moment, Senior Yuan." Shen Shi suddenly said.

"What's the matter?"

"If you need anything at night, just let me know," she said.

"Okay." Yuan nodded and logged off without thinking too much about her words.

Three days later.

"I have come to take you to the Fairy Empress." Elder Xue arrived at their door early in the morning.

"Are you ready to leave, Senior Yuan?" Shen Shi asked him.

"Yes."

Shen Shi then asked him, "Senior, are you not going to wear your Golden Dragon Robe? I think you should wear it when meeting the Fairy Empress."

Yuan looked down and realized that he was still wearing his casual robes.

"Give me a minute to change," he said and went to change into the Golden Dragon Robe.

"Let's go." Yuan appeared before them a few minutes later.

However, Shen Shi didn't respond, and she even looked a bit dazed when she saw him, almost like a girl experiencing love at first sight.

"Are you okay?" Yuan asked her.

"Eh? Y-Yes!" She snapped out of her daze and immediately began blushing.

'He looks completely different when wearing the Golden Dragon Robe! Even his aura changed! This must be a true Dragon Emperor!'

Although Yuan looked like an ordinary person in his casual robes, he truly looked like he belonged to royalty in the Golden Dragon Robe, which caught Shen Shi by surprise.

"Get on." Elder Xue said to them after taking out her flying treasure.

However, Shen Shi declined and said, "It's okay, I have my own."

Then she turned to Yuan and asked him, "Would you like to ride on mine, Senior Yuan?"

"Sure." He nodded, as he didn't have his own flying treasure yet.

Shen Shi then retrieved her flying treasure that was a dragon. It looked very similar to the one used by the Sect Master of the Dragon Essence Temple, but it also looked more majestic and refined.

After jumping onto its head, Shen Shi commanded the flying treasure to follow Elder Xue, who was riding on a large swan.

About three hours later, Yuan could see a massive and majestic castle in the distance.

"Is that where the Fairy Empress lives? What a huge place..." Yuan muttered out loud.

Shen Shi, who heard his mumble, nodded and said, "That's right. It is also home to many powerful experts."

A few more minutes later, they began descending towards the ground.

The moment they landed, Yuan could instantly feel many gazes staring directly at him, and they weren't friendly looks.

Yuan looked around, and sure enough, there were many pretty ladies there looking at him with a look of contempt on their faces.

"Don't worry about them, Senior Yuan. It's common for women in the Fairy Paradise to hate men." Shen Shi comforted him.

"Is there a reason why they harbor such feelings?" Yuan asked out of curiosity.

"A lot of them had been wronged by men in the past, which is the main reason," she said.

"What are you waiting for? Let's hurry up and meet the Fairy Empress." Elder Xue said to them.

While they walked, Shen Shi whispered to Yuan, "Senior, I can tell that you're a calm and humble person after spending the last few days with you, but you should act a little more authoritative when speaking with the Fairy Empress so that she doesn't look down on you."

"Authoritative, huh? I will try." He nodded.

After walking through many hallways and large room, they finally arrived at the main room.

"The Fairy Empress is right behind these doors. If you do anything inappropriate..." Elder Xue narrowed her eyes at them.

"I can say the same to you. If you disrespect the Dragon Emperor..." Shen Shi said.

Elder Xue opened the door and entered the room with Yuan and Shen Shi.

Chapter 621 - Why Dont You Take A Guess?

Chapter 621 - Why Don't You Take A Guess?

"That's the Fairy Empress?" Yuan thought to himself as they approached the figure sitting all the way at the end of the room, and there was another figure standing beside her, who was wearing a uniform that looked similar to Elder Xue's robes.

As for the woman sitting on the throne, she was an extremely beautiful woman with long golden hair and emerald-colored eyes.

"This Junior greets the Fairy Empress." Elder Xue bowed to her.

She then turned to bow to the woman standing beside the Fairy Empress, "This disciple greets the Sect Master."

Seeing Elder Xue greet them, Yuan also prepared to greet them.

However, Shen Shi stopped him from greeting them before stepping forward.

"Fairy Empress! The Royal Dragon Family demands you release the Dragon Emperor as soon as possible! If you keep him detained any longer, we will have no choice but to escalate the situation!"

Yuan stared at Shen Shi with wide eyes.

The Fairy Empress should be the most powerful person in this world, yet Shen Shi dared to speak to her in such a tone.

Either the Dragon Royal Family is as powerful as the Fairy Empress, or she's incredibly daring.

After hearing Shen Shi's words, the Fairy Empress coldly snorted, "Are you threatening me? You have gotten quite daring since our last meeting, Shen

Shi. Have you forgotten about where you are standing right now? That man's life is now in my hands— whether he's the Dragon Emperor or not, so you should watch your mouth and attitude when around me, little girl."

"You can also save your scare tactics for another time, Fairy Empress. You should know very well what will happen to the Fairy Paradise if you harm even a single hair on his body." Shen Shi snorted back.

"Are you sure you want to start a war with the Royal Dragon Family? And it won't just be against my family— but against every Royal Dragon Family in the Nine Heavens."

The Fairy Emperor suddenly burst out laughing that echoed loudly in the large room.

When she eventually stopped laughing, the Fairy Empress suddenly released her cultivation base, instantly pressuring Shen Shi that also affected Yuan even though he was not targeted.

'What powerful pressure! I have never felt anything like this before! What cultivation base is this Fairy Empress at?!' Yuan cried inwardly.

"I will not repeat myself. This is my house, not the Royal Dragon Family, Shen Shi. You will get hurt if you continue barking so loud."

Shen Shi gritted her teeth and also released her cultivation base to retaliate.

However, Yuan suddenly shouted, "Fairy Empress!"

The Fairy Empress immediately stopped her pressure and turned to look at him with interest.

"Did you call me here to fight with her, or do you want to speak with me?" He asked her with a calm face.

"Dragon Emperor, huh? Are you really a Dragon Emperor? How can a Dragon Emperor have such a pathetic cultivation base?" The Fairy Empress spoke after a moment of silence.

"Our ranks are not determined by one's cultivation base but by our bloodline's purity and raw talents." Shen Shi responded.

The Fairy Empress turned to look at Shen Shi with an annoyed look on her face, and she spoke, "Shen Shi, can you let the little emperor speak for himself? You really think I don't know how the Dragon Royal Family works? If you speak any more, I will have you removed until we are done."

"Fairy Empress, I can speak for myself just fine. The only reason I am not being aggressive is because I am in the wrong for entering the Fairy Paradise without permission." Yuan suddenly said.

"However, it appears that I am being treated as a pushover by staying silent, so I will be the one talking now."

"Oh? Then what do you have to say for yourself?" The Fairy Empress no longer bothered with Shen Shi and returned her focus to Yuan.

"Like I'd already mentioned, I acknowledge that I am in the wrong for breaking the rules of this place, but it was not as though I came here on purpose."

"I was accidentally teleported here from another heaven, and I had no control over that whatsoever."

"If you're going to kill me over something like this... then you should be prepared to face the consequences for killing a Dragon Emperor."

"Can you tell me which of the Nine Heavens did you come from?" The Fairy Empress asked him with a calm face.

"That has nothing to do with my situation, so I will not entertain you," Yuan calmly responded.

And he continued, "The real question here is whether you'll kill me or let me go."

After a moment of silence, the Fairy Emperor spoke with a cold grin on her face, "What if I don't kill you... but I will also not let you go? What if I feel

like keeping you imprisoned here forever?"

"You dare?!" Shen Shi exclaimed in an angry voice.

"Of course I dare. Even if the Royal Dragon Family from the upper heavens were to cause trouble here, I also have connections to people in the upper heaven. Don't think you can intimidate me with the royal family."

"And I highly doubt the royal family would want to offend these people for a mere Dragon Emperor. Now if he was a Dragon God, that might be able to save him."

Hearing her words, Yuan suddenly started laughing.

He then said, "Go ahead and imprison me if you want. But before you make that decision, you should know that I have someone waiting for me, and if I don't show up... Let's just say that he'll be very angry."

After saying these words, Yuan retrieved a glass bottle from his Dragon Spatial Ring before tossing it to the Fairy Empress.

"What is this? If you think a drop of blood will save you—" The Fairy Empress suddenly stopped speaking when she took a closer look at the drop of blood in the bottle.

"W-Whose blood essence does this belong to?!" She suddenly shouted in a grim voice, startling everyone there.

"Why don't you take a guess? I will give you a hint... He's the one who created the Royal Dragon Family..." Yuan said with a smile on his face.

Chapter 622 - Blood Essence Of A God-Like Entity

"Y-You don't mean..." Shen Shi covered her mouth in shock after hearing Yuan's words.

"Bullsh*t!" The Fairy Empress suddenly stood up and exclaimed in a somewhat angry manner.

"There's no way this blood essence belongs to the Dragon Ancestor!" She denied his claims.

"I don't blame you for not believing me. I mean, this is the Dragon Ancestor that we're talking about. However, I am not lying to you. If you don't believe me, you can imprison me and wait to find out the truth— though it might be too late then."

The Fairy Empress gritted her teeth after hearing Yuan's words.

Although she cannot tell whether this blood essence truly belonged to the Dragon Ancestor or not, she could tell that the blood essence had come from a god-like being due to the unique spiritual energy the blood essence contained.

While ordinary cultivators all cultivate the same spiritual energy in the air, once they reach a certain cultivation level, they will need to absorb different types of spiritual energy.

For example, a cultivator that has achieved immortality will need to absorb Immortal Qi in order to continue their progress, and the ordinary spiritual energy in their body will eventually be replaced by Immortal Qi.

Above Immortals are god-like beings that can create stars and life with the snap of their finger, and these apex entities will cultivate Celestial Qi, something that the Fairy Empress could sense within the blood essence.

Therefore, even if this blood essence in her grasp doesn't belong to the Dragon Ancestor, it doesn't take away from the fact that it came from a god-like being— someone who has reached the peak of cultivation.

And if it's true that Yuan has connections to a god-like being, nobody in the Fifth Heaven can touch him unless they want to die a horrible death.

After standing there with a perplexed look on her face, the Fairy Empress suddenly started laughing like a maniac.

"You're good— really good, Dragon Emperor! I would've never expected for you to use this kind of method to convince me!"

When she eventually stopped laughing, the Fairy Empress started approaching Yuan with a profound smile on her face.

Shen Shi stood between them when she saw this.

"Get out of my way, Shen Shi." The Fairy Empress said to her in a cold tone.

"I refuse," she instantly responded.

However, Yuan tapped her from behind and said, "It's okay."

Shen Shi gritted her teeth. As much as she wanted to keep him safe from the Fairy Empress, she couldn't disobey a Dragon Emperor who has connections to the Dragon Ancestor himself!

Therefore, she could only reluctantly move out of Fairy Empress' way, allowing her to approach Yuan.

Once the Fairy Empress was in front of Yuan, she returned the Dragon Ancestor's blood essence back to him and said, "I was only teasing you. I have no intentions of harming you, nor do I wish to start a war with the

Royal Dragon Family over something like this. However, since you did break my rules, I had to punish you one way or another."

Yuan was left speechless by the Fairy Empress' words. She had been teasing him this entire time? So it was all an act? He really thought she wanted to keep him imprisoned!

"I-I don't believe you!" Shen Shi exclaimed shortly after hearing the Fairy Empress' words.

"You definitely weren't joking!"

"I don't care if you believe me or not." The Fairy Empress shrugged.

"Though I won't deny that I teased you more than planned because of your big mouth, Shen Shi."

"Does this mean I am free to go?" Yuan asked her.

"Yes. Congratulations on becoming the first man to enter the Fairy Paradise without dying, little emperor."

"Thank you. Now I just need to figure out how I am supposed to return to where I came from..." He sighed.

"Senior, why don't you follow me back to the Royal Dragon Family? Perhaps we can help you figure something out."

Yuan hesitated for a brief moment since they might learn that he was disguising as Dragon Emperor if he followed her back to her family.

"Why don't you just go back through the Stairway to Heaven? If you came from the upper heavens, you don't need to do any trials to go back up there." The Fairy Empress said.

"Unfortunately, my situation is a little special, so I cannot take the Stairway to Heaven." Yuan shook his head.

"Do as you please. Anyways, you are free now, so hurry up and leave this place. If you continue lingering around, I might change my mind and keep you here forever." The Fairy Empress then said.

Yuan nodded and turned to look at Shen Shi, "I'll have to inconvenience your family for a bit."

"It's not an inconvenience! In fact, it's an honor for our royal family to have you, Senior Yuan!" Shen Shi bowed to him.

Sometime later, Yuan left the place with Shen Shi on her flying treasure.

"Is it really okay to let him go?" Elder Xue asked the Fairy Empress after they left.

"We have no choice. The fact that a god-like being has given him their blood essence means he's very important to that person. We cannot afford to offend such a person." The Fairy Empress shook her head.

"What if he'd obtained that blood essence through other means?"

"Even if that might be the case, we cannot risk it. You have no idea how horrifying a god-like entity is. A single one of them could easily wipe out an entire world without sweating."

"Is that so..."

"Anyways, just forget about this incident. If the others ask about it, just say we already took care of him."

"I understand."

Meanwhile, back in the Lower Heavens at the Heavenly Melody Academy.

"Has he not returned yet?" Song Ling'er asked Ai Wan, who has been waiting in front of the Zither Fairy's immortal cave for the last three days.

"No, he hasn't." Ai Wan shook her head.

"Looks like we will have to delay his performance indefinitely until he returns... What a headache."

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Chapter 623 - Visiting The Royal Dragon Family

Somewhere in the Lower Heavens, three figures could be seen soaring through the sky at high speed without the assistance of flying treasures.

"Can either of you feel the Young Master's presence? It suddenly appeared three days ago, but then it disappeared shortly after." A beautiful woman with a lavish figure asked the other two figures, who were a little girl and a graceful young lady.

Of course, these three were Yuan's companions that had gone on a journey without him for the last few months.

"I cannot feel Brother Yuan's presence." Xiao Hua said.

"Me neither." Lan Yingying shook her head.

"And here I thought the Young Master has finally returned to us..." Feng Yuxiang released a deep sigh.

"Anyways, this is where the Young Master's presence disappeared from. It turned out to be the Heavenly Melody Academy." Feng Yuxiang said as they hovered above the Heavenly Melody Academy.

"What should we do now?" Lan Yingying asked.

In response to Lan Yingying's question, Xiao Hua began flying towards the Heavenly Melody Academy, before descending into the inner court.

Xiao Hua's sudden appearance shocked the disciples there, as only Spirit Grandmasters have the capability to fly without the assistance of flying

treasures or flying swords.

And when Feng Yuxiang and Lan Yingying also descended onto the ground from the sky, the disciples' shock turned into fear.

Why did three experts suddenly appear in the middle of their sect?

However, before any disciple could approach them, Song Ling'er noticed their presence and appeared before them.

"I am Song Ling'er, Sect Master of the Heavenly Melody Academy. How can my sect help you?"

"Sect Master Song, we are looking for someone." Feng Yuxiang stepped forward.

"Y-You're... Madam Feng..."

After taking a closer look at their appearances, Song Ling'er recognized them, and they recalled seeing them with the Dragon Essence Temple at the Mystic Realm.

"This person you're looking for... is it Yuan?" Song Ling'er had this gut feeling and asked them.

"Yes, we are. Have you seen him? We stopped whatever we were doing to come here after sensing his presence, but it disappeared shortly after, and we haven't sensed it again since then." Feng Yuxiang nodded.

"Well... You see... What had happened was..." Song Ling'er proceeded to explain to them how Yuan had disappeared after touching the Zither Goddess' immortal cave and has been missing since then.

"What?! He disappeared!? Do you have any idea where he could've went?" Feng Yuxiang asked.

"No, but you can take a look at the place if you wish." Song Ling'er said.

"Take us there!" Xiao Hua immediately said.

"Okay."

Song Ling'er then led the three ladies to the Zither Goddess' immortal cave.

Of course, Ai Wan was still waiting there.

"He disappeared after touching this boulder that seals the entrance." Song Ling'er pointed to the large boulder blocking the entrance.

Feng Yuxiang narrowed her eyes at the boulder for a moment before speaking, "There's a powerful teleport formation within this immortal cave."

"R-Really? Can you do something about this situation?" Song Ling'er asked, feeling a little hopeful.

"I can't say for certain, but we need to go inside to take a closer look at the formation. Can you open it?" Feng Yuxiang said.

"Unfortunately, that's not possible. This immortal cave hasn't been opened since the Zither Goddess left. The only way to open the immortal cave is by forcing it open, but that would destroy the other immortal caves if we're not careful—"

Before Song Ling'er could even finish her sentence, Xiao Hua released her cultivation base and used Qi Manifestation to grab the boulder.

The next second, Xiao Hua yanked the entire boulder away from the entrance, forcefully opening the immortal cave without damaging the other immortal caves.

This left Song Ling'er and Ai Wan completely speechless, as they have never seen an immortal cave being opened in such a forceful manner.

'What cultivation base does she have to achieve such a feat?!' Song Ling'er cried inwardly.

Although she could tell that Feng Yuxiang and Lan Yingying were both at the peak of Spirit Grandmaster, she was unable to see Xiao Hua's

cultivation base.

Then she recalled what happened at the Mystic Realm.

'If I remember correctly, that Senior from the upper heavens called her a Spirit King!'

"Let's go inside." Xiao Hua said as she began walking into the immortal cave without waiting for the others.

Clearly, she was the most anxious one there.

Feng Yuxiang and Lan Yingying followed her inside without hesitation.

Meanwhile, at the Fifth Heaven, after leaving the Fairy Paradise, Shen Shi led Yuan back to her Royal Dragon Family using a teleport treasure, so it only took them a few minutes at most.

After being teleported to right outside her family's living quarters, Shen Shi approached the gates with Yuan behind him.

"Welcome to the Shen Family, Senior Dragon Emperor!" The guards got onto their knees and greeted Yuan the moment they got close enough.

"Welcome back, Young Lady!" They greeted Shen Shi afterward.

Once the guards opened the gates, Shen Shi led Yuan into their living quarters.

However, before they even reached the building in the distance, Yuan could see many figures standing outside the building.

These figures were obviously the Royal Dragon Family that lived in this place.

The Dragon King and his entire family had gathered outside to greet Yuan. It was a privilege that only Dragon Emperors and above could experience.

Once Yuan got close enough, everyone besides the Dragon King and his wife got onto their knees to greet him.

"Greetings, Senior Dragon Emperor!" They all shouted in a loud voice, clearly exhilarated to have a Dragon Emperor visit their home.

As for Yuan, he felt a little guilty for disguising himself as a Dragon Emperor. If these people learn that he's not even a dragon, much less the Dragon Emperor, he could only imagine what they might do to him.

'If they learn the truth, I might as well return to the Fairy Paradise since it would be safer there!' Yuan cried inwardly as he greeted the Shen Family.

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Chapter 624 - Dragon Paradise

"Hello, everyone. Thank you for the warm welcome, but I'd prefer it if you guys acted more casual and informal when around me." Yuan said to them after seeing them treat him as though he was some kind of emperor.

"My name is Yuan, and you can call me as such."

The people there looked at each other with doubtful gazes. Can they really address a Dragon Emperor so casually? They won't receive divine punishment from their ancestor for doing so?

"If you say so— Yuan." The Dragon King said.

"Anyways, let us introduce ourselves."

The royal family then began introducing themselves starting from the Dragon King.

Once everyone there was done, the Dragon King invited Yuan inside the building.

"By any chance, are you hungry? We are preparing for a feast right now." The Dragon King asked him sometime later after they were all sitting down.

"I am a little hungry." Yuan nodded.

"In the meantime, if there's anything we can help you with..."

"I am trying to find a way back to my own world, but I'm not sure how I even got to this place in the first place."

"Can you describe to me what had happened before you came here?" The Dragon King asked.

Yuan proceeded to recall everything that had happened.

"So you touched the entrance of an immortal cave and got teleported here... By the way you described it, I believe it was a teleport formation that specializes in long-distance transportation." The Dragon King said.

"Do you think I was teleported to the Fairy Paradise by accident?" Yuan then asked.

"No, I don't think so. Long-distance transportations usually have a set destination, and they are very precise. If the teleport formation took you to the Fairy Paradise, that means whoever created the teleport formation meant for it to happen."

"Then is there a way to return to my own world? Maybe if I find the teleport formation again..." Yuan then asked.

Back when he was teleported to the Ancient Dragon City, he was able to teleport back using the same teleport, so maybe he could do the same if he can find the Zither Goddess' teleport formation.

However, the Dragon King shook his head and said, "When you appeared in this world, you weren't on top of a teleport formation but high up in the sky, right? This means that the teleport formation that transported you here was a one-way teleport formation."

"So I cannot return to my world?" Yuan mumbled in a low voice.

"If you came from the upper heavens, you can use the Stairway to Heaven to return, but it will be a little tedious." The Dragon King said.

"What if I want to go to the lower heaven?" Yuan suddenly asked.

"The lower heaven?"

The Dragon King raised his eyebrows in a puzzled manner, but he didn't question it and answered, "That would be a little tricky. If you want to go to the lower heaven, you'll need to speak with the lord of this realm to get permission to go to the lower heaven, and the lower you go, the more resources you'll need to expend."

"The lord of this realm? Who is this lord?" Yuan asked.

"That would be the Fairy Empress..."

"She was the lord of this realm?!" Yuan was surprised to learn this information.

'I just left that place too...' He sighed inwardly.

"Are you really trying to go to the lower heaven, Senior Yuan?" Shen Shi asked him.

"Well... I have some business there, so yes..."

The Dragon King pondered for a moment before speaking, "Fortunately, you're only a Spirit Grandmaster, so it will be easier for you to descend—but not by too much, since you'll still need to speak with the Fairy Empress and have the resources to activate the formation."

"I will speak with the Fairy Empress later."

"Thank you." Yuan nodded.

"Is there anything else you want to ask?"

Yuan pondered for a bit before speaking, "Do you know of a place called the Ancient Dragon City?"

He wanted to know how the royal families outside that place view the city.

"The Ancient Dragon City?" The Dragon King seemed to be puzzled by Yuan's question for some reason.

"Yes... Is there something wrong with that place?" Yuan tilted his head in a questioning manner.

"The Ancient Dragon City? Isn't that a mythical world where only dragons live? It's a very popular legend." Shen Shi suddenly said.

"Eh? What do you mean a legend?" Yuan's eyes widened with surprise upon hearing her words.

"You don't know? The Ancient Dragon City is a legendary world that was created during the Primordial Era by the Dragon Ancestor because dragons were hunted for their precious blood, but nobody has ever been to that place — at least nobody in this world." Shen Shi explained.

"A legend..." Yuan mumbled to himself.

"It is also called the Dragon Paradise by some people." Shen Shi added.

"Why are you interested in the Ancient Dragon City?" The Dragon King asked him.

"Don't tell me that you'd actually came from that place?"

Although the Dragon King spoke as though it was a joke, nobody there was laughing, and they just silently stared at Yuan for a response.

"Of course not." Yuan quickly denied coming from the place, which was the truth.

"Then do you think the Ancient Dragon City exists somewhere out there?" Shen Shi asked a moment later.

"I do." Yuan nodded with a profound smile on his face.

Sometime later, the Dragon King was notified that the feast had been prepared, so everyone there began making their way towards the area.

"This feast is to honor the Dragon Emperor's presence!" The Dragon King announced.

Once the cheering stopped, they began feasting on the food, allowing Yuan to show off his eating talents.

"As expected of a Dragon Emperor! Even his food consumption is top-tier!"

"Look at how quickly he's cleaning up the plates! He's treating the food as though they are air!"

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Chapter 625 - Dragon Marble

After entering the Zither Goddess' immortal cave, Xiao Hua and the others immediately began looking around.

However, they quickly realized that besides the teleport formation, there was essentially nothing else inside the immortal cave.

"There's nothing in here..." Song Ling'er was left speechless by this discovery, as she has always believed that there were treasures inside the immortal cave.

Meanwhile, Feng Yuxiang took her time analyzing the formation on the ground despite not being an expert.

"I'm no formation expert, but by the looks of it, this formation is a one-way teleport formation, and judging by the complexity of the design, it's a fairly powerful one."

"Can you tell where it took Brother Yuan?" Xiao Hua asked her.

"Unfortunately, only the creator of this formation would have this information." Feng Yuxiang shook her head.

"Then is there any way to activate it?" Lan Yingying asked.

"You can normally activate a teleport formation by pouring enough spiritual energy inside it, but there are also formations that only activate under certain circumstances. We can try injecting our spiritual energy into this formation, but I don't have any hopes it'll do anything."

"Stand back." Xiao Hua said as she began pouring her spiritual energy into the formation.

However, no matter how much spiritual energy she fed the formation, it remained inactive.

"You said the Young Master played some sort of song with the zither before he was teleported away?" Feng Yuxiang turned to ask Song Ling'er, who nodded.

"Yes, that's what my disciples who were with him at that time said."

Feng Yuxiang sighed and said, "Unless we have a formation master to analyze this formation, we won't be able to tell where it took him, but I doubt there are any formation masters in the Lower Heaven that is skilled enough to handle this formation."

"Is there really nothing we can do?" Lan Yingying asked.

"Unfortunately." Feng Yuxiang shook her head.

"But this is the Young Master that we're talking about. He will be fine no matter where he went. I just hope that he'll return soon."

Meanwhile, in the Fifth Heaven, Yuan was sent to his personal room after the feast.

"If you need anything, just let us know. We'll have someone guarding outside around the clock for you." The Dragon King said to him before leaving.

"Wait a minute." Yuan stopped him before he left.

"Do you know of a Zither Goddess?" He then asked.

"Zither Goddess? I do not, but I can try asking around."

"Is that so... Thank you." Yuan nodded.

Once he was alone, Yuan laid on the bed with a pondering face.

'What should I do now? Even though this is a great chance for me to climb the Nine Heavens, I cannot just leave everyone behind.'

Although he was given this rare chance of skipping four entire realms, allowing him to ascend much faster than other people, he didn't want to leave Xiao Hua and the others behind—he couldn't.

"If only there's something that can help me return..." Yuan sighed out loud as he closed his eyes.

After a few minutes of silence, Yuan suddenly opened his eyes in a snapping manner, almost like he'd realized something.

He then jumped off the bed and began searching inside his Dragon Spatial Ring.

A few moments later, Yuan retrieved a small round object from the Dragon Spatial Ring, and it resembled a marble.

'This is the life-saving treasure that Elder Xuan gave me when I was still a disciple at the Dragon Essence Temple. He said that it could teleport me back to the sect no matter where I am...' Yuan recalled the Dragon Marble that Elder Xuan had given him.

However, he then recalled something else—that it would only work within the Lower Heavens.

'Ah! I forgot! He also mentioned that it would only work if I am within the Lower Heavens...'

After staring at the Dragon Marble for a good moment, Yuan decided to still give it a try without having much hope that it will work.

Yuan took a deep breath and began pouring his spiritual energy into the Dragon Marble.

The Dragon Marble immediately began emitting a bright and golden light that reached every corner inside the room Yuan was in.

Crack!

Yuan could feel the Dragon Marble in his hands quickly heating up, and before he could react, it suddenly exploded into countless fragments, causing the light to intensify many times.

It got so bright that it blinded Yuan, who felt like he was being pointed in every direction by powerful flashlights.

The light began diminishing a few moments later, allowing Yuan to see again.

When Yuan finally opened his eyes and could see his surroundings again, he was surprised to find himself surrounded by people wearing familiar-looking clothes.

"T-They are... Disciples of the Dragon Essence Temple? Did the treasure really bring me back to the sect? I thought it only worked if I was within the Lower Heavens?" Yuan mumbled to himself in a daze.

Indeed, Yuan had been teleported back to the Dragon Essence Temple after using the Dragon Marble.

As for why Elder Xuan said that the Dragon Marble could only be used within the Lower Heavens, it was simply because he didn't know that it could be used even outside the Lower Heaven, as nobody has tried it before until Yuan.

"W-Who are you?! Where did you come from?!" The disciples around Yuan began shouting at him when they snapped out of their daze.

'Judging by their uniform, they should be Outer Court disciples... Anyways, I should hurry up and return to the Heavenly Melody Academy.' Yuan decided to ignore these disciples and return to the Heavenly Melody Academy, shocking the disciples when he suddenly started flying without any flying treasures.

Meanwhile, at the Heavenly Melody Academy, Feng Yuxiang and the others were just about to leave the sect when they suddenly stopped their movements.

"I can sense the Young Master's presence again! The Young Master has returned!" Feng Yuxiang exclaimed in an excited voice.

"What?!" Song Ling'er's eyes widened with shock by this unexpected news.

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Chapter 626 - Something Must Have Happened To Him!

After returning to the Lower Heavens, Yuan immediately began making his way back to the Heavenly Melody Academy.

When he got close enough, Feng Yuxiang's voice suddenly resounded in his head.

"Young Master! Are you okay?!"

"Feng Feng?" Yuan was delighted to hear her voice after so long.

"Where are you right now?" Feng Yuxiang then asked.

"I am currently heading to the Heavenly Melody Academy."

"Is that so... Then we will wait for you here."

"You're at the Heavenly Melody Academy right now? Why?" Yuan asked.

"We sensed your presence here, but it disappeared before we could arrive."

"Ah... I will explain everything to you later once I return."

"Okay. See you later, Young Master."

Feng Yuxiang then explained to Xiao Hua and the others that Yuan was heading back to the Heavenly Melody Academy.

"Is everything okay with Yuan?" Song Ling'er asked.

"Yes, he sounded fine." Feng Yuxiang nodded.

"Thank the heavens... If anything had happened to him..." Song Ling'er released a long sigh of relief after learning that Yuan was not harmed.

Eventually, Yuan managed to return to the Heavenly Melody Academy without any problems.

"Young Master!"

"Brother Yuan!"

"My Lord!"

Xiao Hua and the others immediately rushed to his side, feeling like an eternity since they last met.

"Hello, everyone. It's been a while." Yuan said to them with a gentle smile on his face.

"Yuan, I'm glad that you're fine, but where did you go for the past few days?" Song Ling'er asked him a moment later.

"It's a long story, so let's go back to my living quarter first," Yuan said to them.

As they began making their way to Yuan's temporary living quarters in the sect, Feng Yuxiang would stare at Yuan with a pondering gaze.

"Young Master, did something happen recently?" She decided to ask him.

"Huh? What do you mean?"

"I feel like you had changed a lot since our last meeting."

Yuan couldn't help but smile after hearing her words that Song Ling'er also asked.

"Yes, something did happen. How can you tell?"

"A woman's—"

"Intuition?" Yuan couldn't help but interrupt her.

Feng Yuxiang nodded with a dazed look on her face.

"If you need any help..." Feng Yuxiang then mumbled.

"It was an unfortunate event, but don't worry, I have already taken care of it," he said.

"If you say so..."

Once they arrived at his living quarters and were seated, Yuan began recalling his experience in the Fifth Heaven.

"So I was teleported to a place called Fairy Paradise in the Fifth Heaven..."

"Fifth Heaven?!" Song Ling'er exclaimed in a shocked voice before he could even finish his sentence.

"Yes, and I was imprisoned there for a few days because only females are allowed in the Fairy Paradise. In order to leave, I had to speak with the Fairy Empress and even had the help of the Royal Dragon Family there..."

"Sounds like you had it rough, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Brother Yuan, how did you get back? The teleport formation that transported you was a one-way teleport." Xiao Hua asked him.

"I used a treasure called the Dragon Marble. It was given to me by Elder Xuan at the Dragon Essence Temple. It was supposed to be a life-saving treasure, but I ended up using it to get back here."

"A life-saving treasure that can teleport you from the Fifth Heaven to the Lower Heavens... It must have been an incredibly powerful treasure..." Feng Yuxiang mumbled.

"To be honest with you, I didn't think it'd work. My sudden disappearance will definitely cause some trouble for the Royal Dragon Family since I was staying there as a guest. I only hope that nothing too dramatic happens..." Yuan sighed, as he could only imagine what will happen to the royal family once they realize that he was gone.

"I doubt anything will happen. After all, they're the royal family. Why would they freak out over your disappearance?" Feng Yuxiang said, unaware that Yuan had temporarily taken the identity of a Dragon Emperor while he was there, which will definitely cause some mayhem.

Meanwhile, at the Royal Dragon Family, a few hours after Yuan disappeared, the Dragon King returned to his room.

"I have asked around about 'Zither Goddess' just like you requested and received some information! Are you available now?" The Dragon King knocked on Yuan's room.

When nobody responded, the Dragon King knocked on the door again.

After waiting for a few more moments, the Dragon King turned to look at the guards and asked them, "Did he leave while I was away?"

"No, the Dragon Emperor hasn't left his room."

"Then why isn't he responding?" The Dragon King mumbled to himself.

"Yuan! Are you okay?!" The Dragon King knocked on the door again, feeling a little anxious for some reason.

Eventually, the Dragon King decided to enter the room.

"Excuse me!"

However, to the Dragon King's surprise, the room was empty.

"Are you sure he didn't leave the room? What if he left but you missed it?" The Dragon King returned to the guards with a frown on his face.

"What? That's impossible! We have been watching the entrance since the Dragon Emperor went inside! Unless he left through the windows, we would've definitely noticed him leaving!" The guards exclaimed.

"The windows are still locked, and they can only be locked from the inside! Furthermore, why would the Dragon Emperor leave through the windows? That doesn't make any sense!" The Dragon King said.

"Actually! Now that I think about it, I sensed a slight disturbance coming from the Dragon Emperor's room a while ago, but it disappeared almost as soon as it appeared, so I didn't think too much of it." One of the guards said, unaware that he'd sensed the Dragon Marble's activation.

"Sh*t! I had even scheduled a meeting with the Fairy Empress for the Dragon Emperor! How could he suddenly disappear?!" The Dragon King cursed.

He then turned to look at the guards and commanded, "Find out what happened to the Dragon Emperor! I don't believe that he'd leave without telling us! Something must have happened to him and I want to know what!"

Chapter 627 - Kidnapped!

After commanding the guards to look for Yuan, the Dragon King gathered his family to notify them of the situation.

"What?! Senior Yuan disappeared from his room?!" Shen Shi exclaimed in a shocked voice.

And she continued, "Are you sure he didn't leave his room to go somewhere?"

"I have confirmed this with the guards— he hasn't left his room since he entered it, and the windows were still locked when I went to check on him." The Dragon King shook his head.

"Furthermore, the guards had sensed a disturbance inside his room before he disappeared, so there's a good chance that something had forced him to disappear."

"Why would anyone want to kidnap the Dragon Emperor?" Someone there asked.

"Maybe it's the Fairy Paradise! What if they released him so that they cannot be held accountable if anything happens to him afterward?!" Another person there speculated.

"That makes sense! How despicable!"

"It must be the Fairy Paradise! I found it suspicious how they allowed the Dragon Emperor to leave so easily!"

The majority of the royal family believed that the Fairy Paradise was responsible for Yuan's disappearance at this point.

"Calm down, everyone." The Dragon King eventually spoke.

"Although we are not always on good terms, I know the Fairy Empress very well. She is not the type to do something like this— at least I hope that's the case. Anyways, I will speak with the Fairy Empress later. Until then, you guys try to look for the Dragon Emperor."

"If he doesn't show up and the people from the upper heaven begins looking for him, we'll be responsible for his disappearance, as he'd disappeared while inside our territory! This will look incredibly bad for our royal family!"

The others began mumbling to each other.

Indeed, if someone had to take the blame for Yuan's disappearance, their royal family would be first on the list since Yuan had disappeared while staying in their family, and that could be disastrous for their family, especially since Yuan had connections to the one and only Dragon Ancestor!

"Uses whatever resources we have to find the Dragon Emperor! We will not rest until we find him or find whoever is responsible for his disappearance!"

Thus began the royal family's investigation on Yuan's disappearance that would lead them across the entire Fifth Heaven.

Meanwhile, the Dragon King went to meet the Fairy Empress outside the Fairy Paradise.

"Dragon King, why did you summon me? What is so urgent that you cannot wait for a few more days until my meeting with the Dragon Emperor?" The Fairy Empress asked him.

The Dragon King didn't want to waste any time and went straight into the topic, "The Dragon Emperor is missing. He'd suddenly disappeared from his room."

"What?" The Fairy Empress frowned upon hearing this information.

And then she spoke in a grim voice, "I hope you didn't call me here just to accuse me of kidnapping him or something like that, right?"

"To be completely honest with you, many people in my family believe the Fairy Paradise had something to do with his disappearance—"

Before the Dragon King could even finish his sentence, the Fairy Empress shouted in a loud voice, "You dare?!"

Her cultivation base exploded from her body, causing the surroundings to tremble.

However, the Dragon King remained calm and continued to speak, "Calm down, Fairy Empress. If I am going to blame you for his disappearance, would I even be here?"

The Fairy Empress retrieved her cultivation base after hearing his words, but the frown remained on her face.

"It's fact that the Dragon Emperor had disappeared, and he's only a Spirit Grandmaster, so it wouldn't take much effort for anybody above Spirit King to kidnap him. However, the question is who would kidnap him."

"I will tell you right now that the Fairy Paradise had nothing to do with his disappearance! If you dare blame us for it, we will not sit still and let you accuse us!" The Fairy Empress said.

If their Fairy Paradise takes blame for Yuan's disappearance and the god-like entity shows up, it would be disastrous for the Fairy Paradise.

In other words, unless they find Yuan, both the Fairy Paradise or the Royal Dragon Family could face severe consequences.

"I believe you, so why don't we cooperate to find out the real culprit behind his disappearance? If we don't find him and the people from the upper heavens show up, we'll both get in trouble."

The Fairy Empress didn't immediately respond and took a moment to ponder.

"Do you even have to think about this? If you don't help me, it will only make the Fairy Paradise look guilty! Furthermore, you imprisoned him for three days and even threatened to kill him!"

"Che!" The Fairy Empress coldly snorted.

"Fine, we will help you search for the Dragon Emperor."

"Thank you."

The Dragon King remained with the Fairy Empress for a little longer to explain the situation in more detail.

Meanwhile, in the Lower Heaven, Yuan was completely oblivious to the chaos that he'd caused by disappearing.

"Anyways, that's my story. What about you guys? What have you been doing for the past few months? Did you get a good look at the Lower Heavens, Yingying?" Yuan asked them after explaining his situation.

"Yes, I got to visit many places from all four continents. It was a great experience, and I even managed to increase my cultivation to the peak of Spirit Grandmaster from all the treasures we found." Lan Yingying said.

"Sounds like you guys had a great time," Yuan said with a smile on his face.

"What are your plans now, Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang suddenly asked him.

"Once I am done here, I will be challenging the Stairway to Heaven," he calmly responded.

"Eh? Really? I thought you wanted to explore the Lower Heavens a little more before leaving."

"That was my original plan, but I have more important priorities now."

He then turned to look at Song Ling'er and continued, "I missed the performance, right?"

"Don't worry about it."

"Do you still want me to do it?" Yuan asked.

"Of course! I will gather the disciples again! We will be ready for your performance tomorrow!" Song Ling'er eagerly nodded.

"Great," Yuan said.

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Chapter 628 - Fourth Level Spirit Grandmaster

After letting Yuan know that she will gather the disciples tomorrow for his performance, Song Ling'er left the place.

"We have some time until tomorrow, so why don't you tell me a little about your adventure?" Yuan then asked the three ladies in the room.

"It honestly wasn't that exciting, as we'd spent most of our time wandering and killing magical beasts so that Lan Yingying could consume them." Feng Yuxiang said.

"That's fine. Even if it's boring, I want to hear all of it." Yuan said with a calm smile on his face.

Lan Yingying nodded, and she proceeded to recall their adventure with Yuan, which took up the rest of the day.

"I'm glad that nobody was hurt," Yuan said to them after hearing their story, as they'd encountered a few dangerous-sounding situations.

Of course, even though it sounded like they were in danger, the truth was anything but that, as they were all peak experts of this world, and with a Spirit King like Xiao Hua with them, it was impossible to get hurt even if they want to get hurt.

"What about you, Young Master? That is if you don't mind sharing." Feng Yuxiang asked him out of curiosity.

"Well, I had to fight a demon and was nearly killed," Yuan said with a bittersweet smile on his face.

"WHAT?!" Feng Yuxiang exclaimed in a shocked voice.

"D-Demon?! A real demon?!" Even Lan Yingying was startled by the news.

"Yes, a real demon."

"But how is that possible? I thought they only existed in the Mystic Realm..." Feng Yuxiang mumbled in a low voice.

"It was a sealed demon that had broken out of its seal after being sealed for many years," he sighed.

"Is this demon the reason why you're sad, Brother Yuan?" Xiao Hua suddenly asked him.

Even though he appears to be fine, Xiao Hua could tell that he was experiencing sorrow from his aura after staying with him for so long.

"Yes, this demon killed a precious friend of mine because I was too weak to defeat it."

"Too weak...?" Lan Yingying was in disbelief.

She had personally witnessed him fighting and defeating the Demon Lord that is at the Spirit Lord realm. If even he cannot defeat this demon, it must have been at least Spirit King!

Unbeknownst to Lan Yingying, the demon was only a peak Spirit Master. However, due to Yuan's situation and lower cultivation base, it was not something he could defeat at that moment. If it weren't for the Divine Paragon, Yuan would've definitely died on that day.

"I'm sorry you had to go through that, Young Master..." Feng Yuxiang said to him.

"Why are you apologizing?" Yuan smiled, and he continued, "I can only blame myself for being too weak, and I made a promise to myself that I will never make the same mistake again."

"If you need any help, just let us know, Young Master! I have plenty of treasures that can assist your cultivation!"

"Then I would like to temper my body whenever I am free. Just make sure you don't put that weird stuff inside this time..." Yuan said, as he could still recall what happened last time very clearly.

"I-I understand." Feng Yuxiang nodded with a bashful smile.

Sometime later, Yuan logged off the game to eat dinner with the others.

"I have managed to reunite with Feng Feng and the others," Yuan told Meixiu during dinner.

"How are they doing?"

"They're doing great."

"Who's Feng Feng?" Chu Liuxiang asked them afterward.

"They are our companions in Cultivation Online. We travel together as a group." Yuan explained.

"I see..."

"Speaking of Cultivation Online, do you want to play with us?" Yuan asked Chu Liuxiang.

"Honestly, I am not a big fan of that game. Although I admire their amazing world, it's too much work. I don't want to cultivate again from scratch, especially since I am already a Spirit Master in real life." Chu Liuxiang shrugged.

"However, if you want me to play with you, I won't refuse."

"Well, I am planning on challenging the Stairway to Heaven very soon so that I can ascend to the next world. I can take a few people with me, but once I leave the Lower Heavens, it will be very hard for me to return."

Chu Liuxiang pondered for a moment before nodding her head, "Okay, I will come with you."

"What about you, Meixiu? You're also coming, right?"

"Yes." She quickly nodded.

There was no way that she'd accept getting left behind while Chu Lixuiang follows him to the upper heavens.

After dinner, instead of going to sleep or cultivating like usual, Yuan returned to Cultivation Online.

"Feng Feng, I'd like to start tempering my body now if you don't mind," Yuan said.

"Of course! I have already prepared all the necessary treasures for you."

"Great."

Yuan then entered the bathroom with Feng Yuxiang.

After filling the large bathtub with hot water, Feng Yuxiang tossed a few treasures into the water, and it appeared to be less than what she used last time.

"Although there is less medicine this time, the effects are actually a little stronger than previously, so you'll experience a little more pain."

"That's perfectly fine." Yuan nodded.

"I will be waiting for you outside, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang then took a moment to make sure everything was done properly before leaving the bathroom to Yuan.

Once he was alone, Yuan removed his clothes and entered the bathtub.

He began absorbing the medicine shortly after.

"Ah! This is pain is a hundred times worse than the medicine bath I got at the Jaded Garden!" Yuan exclaimed, feeling intense pain all over his body.

While the pain wasn't that much higher than his last tempering in Cultivation Online, because it has been a while since he did it, he was no longer adapted to the pain.

After spending a few gruesome hours absorbing the medicine and enduring the pain that came from it, Yuan managed to breakthrough to the fourth level Spirit Grandmaster.

[You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough]

[You have reached fourth level Spirit Grandmaster]

[+28,000 Stats]

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Chapter 629 - Performing For The Heavenly Melody Academy

Yuan emerged from the bathtub after absorbing all of the medicine, which helped him breakthrough to the next level of Spirit Grandmaster.

"Congratulations on your breakthrough, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang said to him when she noticed him coming out of the bathroom.

"It's all thanks to your treasures." Yuan smiled.

And he continued, "I don't really know how to repay you."

"You don't have to repay me, Young Master. I am your servant, thus everything that belongs to me also belongs to you."

"I am not that shameless to accept free things without returning a favor. Furthermore, it's all precious treasures that would definitely cost a fortune if you were to sell them. I cannot accept that much for free."

"However, the only thing I can really give you right now is my blood." Yuan sighed.

"Speaking of my blood... I haven't given you any of my blood for some time now. Do you want to drink some right now?" Yuan then asked her after realizing this.

Feng Yuxiang shook her head with a bittersweet smile.

"Is there something wrong? You are normally very excited for my blood." Yuan asked her.

"There's nothing wrong, Young Master. It's just that... I am afraid that you might cure my curse too quickly, forcing me to return to the upper heavens," she finally decided to reveal her reason for her hesitation.

"Isn't that what you wanted? To cure the curse as soon as possible?" Yuan raised his eyebrows in a confused manner.

"Indeed, that's what I wanted at first, but after spending some time with you, I realized that I wanted to stay by your side for a little longer. If I consume your blood and the curse breaks, my cultivation will no longer be suppressed, so I will have to return to the upper heavens, and I don't want that to happen."

Yuan remained silent for a moment before speaking, "If that's your choice, I will support it. Of course, if you ever change your mind or want to drink my blood, just let me know."

"I will. Thank you, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang nodded with a gentle smile.

"Anyways, I will be back later," Yuan said before logging off for breakfast.

During breakfast, Yuan asked Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang, "What do you two usually do now?"

"I spend most of my time cultivating," Meixiu said.

"I spend all of my time staring at your face." Chu Liuxiang responded with a calm face.

"..."

Although he wanted to say something about Chu Liuxiang's response, he didn't know what to say, as he was baffled speechless by her response.

Chu Liuxiang chuckled at his reaction and said, "I am joking, Brother Yuan. I only spend a few hours staring at your face. As for the other hours, I either cultivate or surf the internet for a headquarter for our faction."

"A few hours still sounds like a lot..." Yuan shook his head.

After breakfast, Yuan returned to his room and entered Cultivation Online.

Song Ling'er showed up to his living quarters shortly after, and Ai Wan was there with her.

"Yuan! I'm so glad that you're okay!" Ai Wan could finally feel relief after seeing his face.

Even though Song Ling'er had told her about Yuan's return yesterday, she still felt anxious for some reason. However, that feeling completely disappeared the moment she saw Yuan's face.

"I'm sorry for making you worried," Yuan said to her.

"No, I should be apologizing to you. If I didn't bring you there..."

"It's fine. It was a unique experience, so I don't mind it."

He then turned to look at Song Ling'er and asked her, "I forgot to ask you this yesterday, but what's going to happen to the Zither Goddess' immortal cave?"

"I have sealed it back up since there's nothing besides the teleport formation inside, and I don't want another person to fall victim and accidentally teleport to the Fifth Heaven. Although you were lucky enough to return with the Dragon Marble, I doubt the others will be as lucky."

"I understand. Thank you." Yuan said to her.

"Anyways, are you ready for the performance? The disciples will be gathered two hours from now." Song Ling'er asked him.

"Two hours, huh? I will use this time to warm up."

Thus, Yuan proceeded to spend the next two hours playing random songs on the zither to warm his fingers up even though it was unnecessary for someone at his level to do such a thing.

Once it was time for the performance, Yuan followed Song Ling'er outside the sect until they arrived at this spacious area that was a couple of miles behind the Heavenly Melody Academy.

"Wow, there's a lot of people here..." Lan Yingying mumbled to herself as they flew over tens of thousands of disciples from the Heavenly Melody Academy.

The disciples on the ground also noticed them.

"Look! It's the Sect Master!"

"Who are those following behind her?! I have never seen so many Spirit Grandmasters together at once until today!"

"I wonder what this gathering is about..."

A few moments later, Song Ling'er brought Yuan to this tall platform in the center of the sea of disciples.

She then turned to look at the disciples before announcing in a loud and clear voice, "I have gathered all of you here today to witness a zither performance performed by Daoist Yuan, who is a musical genius."

"What? The Sect Master gathered us for a mere zither performance?"

"The Sect Master wouldn't gather us for something ordinary."

"Hey! I recognize that man standing behind her! That's the person who played 'God Descends from Heaven' flawlessly at the Music Pagoda!"

"What? He's that rumored mysterious genius that everyone has been talking about lately?"

"Does this mean he'll be performing for us? Hell yeah! I have been dreaming of this moment since I witnessed his performance at the Music Pagoda!"

The atmosphere there quickly became rowdy.

"Whenever you're ready, Yuan." Song Ling'er said to him.

"What song should I play?" He asked.

"It doesn't matter... After all, whatever you play will turn out to be flawless," she smiled.

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Chapter 630 - Seven Songs

Yuan took a moment to ponder what songs he wanted to play.

"Senior Song, I can play multiple songs, right?"

"Of course! You can play as many songs as you'd like," she immediately responded.

Yuan nodded and took a seat on the platform before retrieving his Soul Ensnaring Zither.

A couple of disciples there recognized the Soul Ensnaring Zither, as they'd tried to play it before.

"Is that the real Soul Ensnaring Zither?"

"The one that used to be owned by the Zither Goddess?"

"It's probably just a replica, right?"

"No, I heard that someone had managed to obtain it after successfully playing it."

As the disciples murmured to each other, Yuan pulled on the string of the zither and began his first of many songs that would be played on that day.

When the disciples heard the music note, they immediately closed their mouths and focused on Yuan, who was calmly sitting on the platform.

The first song that Yuan decided to play was something Fei Yuyan had taught him.

The second song was something from his own world.

The third and fourth song was something he learned from the ninth floor of the Music Pagoda.

The fifth and sixth song was also from the Music Pagoda, and it was on the tenth floor.

And lastly, Yuan decided to play God Descends from Heaven for his seventh and final song.

Yuan's performance that was played with barely any breaks in-between left the disciples there breathless. If he didn't take a few moments between each song, the audience would have collapsed from forgetting how to breathe.

Furthermore, if one looked at the crowd closely, one would notice many disciples sitting down in the lotus position, appearing to be cultivating, as they had received slight enlightenment from Yuan's performance.

"Is this good enough?" Yuan asked Song Ling'er after playing his last song, snapping her out of her daze.

"Y-Yes. That was more than good enough," she said.

"That's great." Yuan stood up and stored the Soul Ensnaring Zither back into his storage ring.

"Are you leaving now?" Song Ling'er asked him.

"Yes," he nodded.

As much as he wanted to look around the Heavenly Melody Academy a little longer, he didn't want to delay his ascension to the next heaven any longer.

"If you ever get the chance to visit again, our doors will always be open for you." Song Ling'er said to him.

"Thank you. I will definitely visit if I ever return to the Lower Heavens."

"Where to now, Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang asked him.

"Let's give the Dragon Essence Temple a visit before we leave, not to mention I have someone to pick up from that place," Yuan said.

After saying their goodbyes to Song Ling'er, Yuan and the others began making their way to the Dragon Essence Temple.

"S-Sect Master! Who was that young man?!"

The sect elders swarmed Song Ling'er after Yuan left the scene.

"A friend I made not long ago," she said with a profound smile on her face.

Meanwhile, at the Dragon Essence Temple, Sect Master Long Yijun sat before the high-ranking sect elders with a solemn expression on his face.

"Have we gotten any new information regarding the Spirit Grandmaster that suddenly appeared in our sect before flying away?" He asked the sect elders.

After Yuan returned to the sect using the Dragon Marble, the disciples that witnessed the scene had reported it to them, hence the current situation.

"They said it was a young man wearing black and golden robes... I can only think of one person with that description..." Elder Xuan said.

"You think it's Yuan? But why would he suddenly show up in the sect and leave without saying anything?" Elder Shan said.

"That's what I am trying to figure out as well. However, besides him, I cannot think of another young Spirit Grandmaster." Elder Xuan shrugged.

"I just hope his appearance isn't something ominous. We've been targeted a lot recently because of what happened at the Mystic Realm." Long Yijun sighed.

It was at this moment Elder Xuan noticed his communication jade slip trembling.

Upon answering it, Elder Xuan could hear Yuan's voice resound inside his head.

"Senior Xuan, I am heading to the Dragon Essence Temple right now."

"Y-Yuan? Did something happen?" Elder Xuan asked him in a slightly dazed voice.

"Did you just say Yuan?" Everybody there turned to look at Elder Xuan with wide eyes.

"Yes, and he said that he's currently on his way here."

"Really? Did he say why?" Long Yijun asked.

"No, but I will ask him right now."

"Is there a specific reason why you're returning now?" Elder Xuan asked Yuan.

"Not really. I will be challenging the Stairway to Heaven soon, and I wanted to visit the Dragon Essence Temple one last time and personally say goodbye."

"The Stairway to Heaven?!" Elder Xuan exclaimed in a shocked voice.

After all, it hasn't been long since Yuan left their sect! A few months at most!

"Anyways, I am almost there, so I will talk to you again when I am there," Yuan said before hanging up.

Elder Xuan then told the others what Yuan had said to him.

"What? He's climbing the Stairway to Heaven already?" Elder Shan mumbled in a dumbfounded voice.

"He's truly in a league of his own." Long Yijun said.

"He's a Spirit Grandmaster, right? That's when people usually challenge the Stairway to Heaven, so I guess it's not that surprising."

"Cancel all of my plans and appointment today. I have an important guest that requires company." Long Yijun said a moment later.

Sometime later, Yuan and the others arrived at the Dragon Essence Temple.

"I missed this place..." Yuan mumbled to himself as he gazed upon the entire sect from the sky.

Once he had enough of the view, Yuan proceeded to make his way towards the Sect Master's headquarters.

"Welcome back, Yuan..." Long Yijun and the other sect elders greeted him with broad smiles on their faces.

Chapter 631 - Fei Yuyans Decision

Chapter 631 - Fei Yuyan's Decision

"Hello, everyone. It's been a while." Yuan greeted Long Yijun and the other sect elders.

"It's only been a few months. This amount of time is nothing in the cultivation world." Elder Xuan said with a smile on his face.

"Madam Feng... Seniors... Welcome to the Dragon Essence Temple." Long Yijun then greeted Feng Yuxiang and the others.

"I heard you're going to challenge the Stairway to Heaven soon, is that right? You grow up so quickly." Elder Shan approached him until she was standing directly behind him.

She then wrapped her arms around him and embraced him in a playful manner.

"I swear it wasn't long ago that you were a Spirit Warrior. Your talents are screwing with my sense of time," she sighed.

Although the others would normally call out her shamelessness, the sect elders remained silent this time.

Once she had enough, Elder Shan released Yuan and asked him, "Are you going to challenge the Stairway to Heaven right after leaving this place?"

"I still have one place to visit after this, but once that is done, I will challenge the stairway," he said.

"How long do you plan on staying here?" Elder Xuan asked him.

"I probably won't stay too long since I only have to pick up someone before I am ready to leave."

"Who are you picking up?" Long Yijun raised his brows.

"Min Li," he calmly said.

"Eh? Min Li from the Min Family? Why are you picking her up?" Long Yijun continued to ask.

"I am going to bring her with me to the Stairway to Heaven," he responded.

"What?! She's also going to challenge the Stairway to Heaven?!" The people there were surprised to learn this information.

"But she's only a Spirit Warrior! There's no way she'll succeed!"

Yuan waved his hand and said, "That's not it. I will be helping her climb the stairway, so she doesn't actually have to climb it herself."

Everyone there stared at him with wide eyes.

Long Yijun then spoke with a frown on his face, "Yuan... You are aware that by helping her, it will make your climb much more difficult, right?"

"Yes, I am well aware of it."

"And you're still willing to help her? You're really too kind, Yuan..." Elder Xuan said with a warm smile on his face.

"Hm? But wait a moment... Min Li from the Min Family had to return to her family's headquarters for some reason, so she's not in the sect at this moment." Elder Bai suddenly said.

"What? When did this happen?" Long Yijun asked, as he was not aware of this information.

"Last week. I saw it in the reports, but I didn't think it was worth mentioning to you, so I didn't say anything. After all, people from the Legacy Families are always going back and forth, so this isn't anything unusual."

"Min Li is not at the sect? Do you know when she will return?" Yuan then asked.

"Unfortunately, she didn't leave behind any additional notes, so we don't know when she'll return."

"Hmm... How far away is the Min Family? I think it would be quicker if I go there instead."

"The Min Family isn't that far away. In fact, you can get to that place in just a few hours if you use teleport formations." Elder Xuan said.

"Sounds good. I will visit her after I say goodbye to a few disciples." Yuan nodded.

"By disciples, do you mean my disciple, Fei Yuyan?" Elder Shan asked.

"Yes. I hope she's not busy."

"She's usually training at this time, but I'm sure that she wouldn't mind your presence for a bit. I will take you to her right now if you want."

"Sure."

After talking with the others for a bit longer, Yuan followed Elder Shan to the Blossom Peak, where Fei Yuyan was training with the other disciples.

"Yuyan! You have a visitor!"

"A visitor?" Fei Yuyan turned around after hearing Elder Shan's voice.

"Eh...? Y-Yuan...? Is that really you?" Fei Yuyan doubted her eyes for a moment when she saw him.

"Yes, it's me. I have come to visit you... and to say goodbye." Yuan said as he approached her.

"Goodbye?" Fei Yuyan frowned slightly.

"I will be challenging the Stairway to Heaven soon. If I succeed, I will no longer be in the Lower Heavens," he said.

"Oh, right... You did say that before you left the sect. Well... Good luck. Though I'm sure you'll succeed with ease."

Although she wanted to say more to him, she wasn't sure what else to say to him, as his sudden appearance had baffled her speechless.

"Disciple Fei, do you remember what we talked about before I left?" Yuan suddenly asked her.

"What we talked about?" Fei Yuyan began pondering.

"Are you going to ask me if I want to follow you to the upper heavens?" Fei Yuyan said after a long moment of silence.

"That's right. If you want to go to the upper heavens, I can help you. Have you thought about it after I left?" Yuan nodded.

"Of course, I have thought about it." Fei Yuyan nodded.

"Then can you tell me your decision?"

Fei Yuyan looked at Yuan straight in the eyes for a few seconds before speaking, "Unlike Disciple Min, I do not have any big ambitions. I am satisfied with what I have right now, and even if I receive your help to reach the upper heavens, I won't truly feel like I belong there."

She paused for a moment to take a deep breath before continuing, "Therefore, I will have to decline your offer."

"I understand." Yuan nodded.

"Wait..." Fei Yuyan suddenly began blushing, and she spoke a moment later, "It's not that I don't want to follow you. In fact, I want to follow you to the upper heavens and spend more time with you, but I don't want to be a burden."

"Burden? You are not—"

"Don't." Fei Yuyan suddenly interrupted.

"Don't tell me that I am not a burden. It will only make me feel worse. Please..."

"..."

Seeing the painful smile on Fei Yuyan's face, Yuan decided to not continue his sentence and merely nodded in silence.

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Chapter 632 - Going To The Min Family

"Hey, Yuan, before you leave, can we play the zither again for a bit?" Fei Yuyan suddenly asked him after a moment of awkward silence.

"Of course." He immediately agreed.

"Let's do it at my backyard like we used to."

"Okay."

Fei Yuyan turned to look at Elder Shan and said, "I'm sorry, Master, but I will end my training early today."

"Do as you please." Elder Shan nodded.

Yuan then followed Fei Yuyan back to her living quarters.

Once they were in the backyard, they sat down beside each other with their zither out.

"The Soul Ensnaring Zither? What happened to the Divine-grade zither you obtained at the competition?" Fei Yuyan asked him.

"Oh, that thing? I sold it." Yuan casually said.

"Y-You sold a Divine-grade treasure...?" Fei Yuyan's eyes widened with disbelief.

"I didn't need it since I already have the Soul Ensnaring Zither, and I needed the money back then." Yuan shrugged.

"But the Soul Ensnaring Zither isn't really a treasure..."

"While that is true, it still performs the same if not a little better than the Divine-grade zither."

"In the end, it's not like I will be using it as a weapon, so it really doesn't matter to me."

"I guess so..."

"Anyways, which song should we play first?" Yuan then asked.

"I am fine with any song."

"Then why don't we play the songs that we played during our practice session before the zither competition?" Yuan suggested.

"Sure." Fei Yuyan nodded.

A few moments later, they began playing the zither together, and they would spend the next few hours playing without any breaks.

At the end of their duet, Fei Yuyan stood up and bowed to him, "Thank you for playing with me."

"There's no need to thank me. We're partners, remember?" Yuan said with a smile on his face.

"Partners..." Although Fei Yuyan knew that Yuan was only talking about their partnership for the zither competition, it still made her incredibly happy to hear such words coming from him.

"Are you going to leave now?" She then asked him.

"Not yet. I still have to visit Xuan Wuhan before I can leave."

"I understand. Once again, good luck with the Stairway to Heaven, Yuan."

"Thank you."

After saying their goodbyes to each other, Yuan made his way to Xuan Wuhan's living quarters.

"Hm?" Yuan noticed a figure standing outside Xuan Wuhan's living quarter when he approached it, and it turned out to be Xuan Wuhan herself.

"Yuan!" Xuan Wuhan immediately called out to him when she noticed his figure.

"Hello. Are you waiting for somebody?"

"Yes— you! I heard from my grandfather that you have returned to the sect, and I figured that you might visit me, so I have been waiting for you since then." Xuan Wuhan said with a bright smile on her face.

"Waiting for me? What if I didn't show up?" Yuan chuckled.

"Then I would have chased you down!"

After laughing a bit, Xuan Wuhan said, "Even though I have known you for less than a year, it feels like we've been friends forever."

"Good luck with the Stairway to Heaven, Yuan. With your talents, I'm sure you'll be able to pass it without any issues."

And she continued, "Hey, Yuan, this may be a bit sudden, but do you want to grab something to eat at the Dragon Pavilion before you leave?"

"Of course! I was actually thinking about returning to that place too."

"Then let's go!"

Xuan Wuhan and Yuan proceeded to head to the Dragon Pavilion for a feast.

As usual, Yuan ordered the entire menu without hesitation.

After they finished eating, Yuan said his goodbyes to Xuan Wuhan.

"Yuan... I will definitely try to ascend the Stairway to Heaven in the future — with my own strength. Although I already know that it's not likely to happen, I will still try to catch up with you."

"Good luck to you. I really hope to see you again." Yuan nodded.

"Of course."

After talking for a little longer, Yuan returned to Long Yijun and the other sect elders to say his final goodbyes with them.

"Goodbye, everyone. I will never forget my experience as a disciple in the sect." Yuan bowed to them.

"And we'll never forget having a disciple like you, Yuan." Long Yijun and the others returned his bow.

Yuan left the Dragon Essence Temple shortly after.

"Where to now, Young Master?"

"The Min Family to pick up Min Li," he calmly replied.

Then he realized that he didn't have their location.

"I should have asked them about the Min Family's location before I left..." Yuan sighed.

"The Min Family, right? I know where they are located. In fact, they used to be frequent customers of mine." Feng Yuxiang suddenly said.

"That's great."

"Follow me."

Feng Yuxiang then led Yuan and the others to a nearby city to use their teleport formation.

A couple of hours later, they arrived in Min City, and just by the name itself, anyone could tell that it was the Min Family who governs this land.

After entering the city, Feng Yuxiang led Yuan straight to the Min Family's headquarters, which was located at the center of the city.

"That large and red building over there is the Min Family, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang pointed to the obvious building in the distance that stuck out like a sore thumb.

"Alright. Let's go."

Yuan approached the guards standing by the gates, and as expected of one of the Seven Legacy Families, they don't play around with security, as there were dozens of guards surrounding the place, and they were only the ones working at the gates.

"W-What business do you have with the Min Family?" The guards there asked him when they got close enough, but they appeared to be a little bit flustered for some reason.

However, if one looked at the direction of their gazes, that reason would become obvious.

Of course, they were flustered after seeing the beauties with Yuan.

Chapter 633 - Not Accepting Any Visitors

"Hello, I am here to see Min Li. I was told by the Dragon Essence Temple that she had returned home not long ago." Yuan said to the guards while they were still dazed by the beauties around him.

"Y-Young Lady Min? What business do you have with her?"

"I am here to fulfill a promise I made to her."

"I'm sorry, but the Min Family is not accepting any visitors at this moment, as they are currently preparing for the Young Lady's marriage." The guard then said, taking Yuan by surprise.

"What? Marriage? Min Li is getting married?"

"Yes, the Min Family suddenly announced her marriage with Gu Tao from the Gu Family, their third eldest son."

"The Gu Family..." Yuan recalled when someone from the Gu Family tried to recruit him to their family when he was still a disciple of the Dragon Essence Temple, and he mentioned that the Gu Family was one of the Seven Legacy Families.

As for Min Li marrying this Gu Tao, it was obviously something that her family decided for her.

Yuan could still remember Min Li pleading with him to join her family so that they wouldn't do something like this to her.

'Looks like I had made her wait too long...' Yuan sighed inwardly.

However, knowing that Min Li was most likely forced into this marriage by her family, Yuan was more inclined to meet with her.

"Hey, my Young Master said he wants to meet with Min Li. I don't care if the Min Family is accepting visitors or not, he will meet her today!" Feng Yuxiang suddenly said with a cold expression on her pretty face.

"Who do you think you are? If you think you can say whatever you want just because you are a little pretty, then—"

Before the guard could even finish his sentence, Feng Yuxiang retrieved a medallion from her storage ring and shoved it right in his face.

The guard was startled at first, but when he realized what Feng Yuxiang was holding, it turned into shock and fear.

"T-The Min Family's Royal Guest Medallion! Why do you have something like that?!" The guard exclaimed in a shocked voice.

"Does it matter why I have it? The question here is whether you will let my Young Master meet Min Li or not."

The guards gritted their teeth as they were in a predicament.

On one hand, the Min Family said no guests are allowed, but on the other, the Royal Guest Medallion is the highest honor one could receive from the Min Family, and those with the medallion must be treated as though they are part of the family!

This rule was set by the founder of the Min Family, so it wasn't something they could simply ignore!

"M-May I ask for your name, Senior?" One of the guards asked her.

"Feng Yuxiang," she calmly responded.

"Wait! Aren't you Madam Feng from the Golden Phoenix Bazaar?!" Someone there recognized her name.

"Yes, I used to work at the Golden Phoenix Bazaar," Feng Yuxiang nodded, not denying her identity.

"O-Open the gates for them!" The guard then said.

"Are you sure?" The others asked him.

"Yes! Just open it!"

The guards nodded their heads and opened the gates for them.

"Please excuse us for the inconvenience just now, Madam Feng. Please, follow me. I will bring you to the Young Lady." The guard said to her.

Once Yuan and the others disappeared with the guard, the other guards began mumbling to each other.

"Who is Madam Feng?"

"You don't know? She used to own the most popular and valuable stores in the Golden Phoenix Bazaar. The Min Family also used to be a frequent customer there, so they highly respect her." One of the more senior guards there explained to the others.

Meanwhile, inside the Min Family's living quarters, Min Li sat inside her room with a tranquil expression on her face as she stared outside her window.

"I knew I shouldn't have returned... I knew it was a trap, yet I still returned... I am such an idiot..." Min Li sighed.

It was mostly due to how she was raised to listen to her parents regardless of the situation, hence why she returned to the family after being summoned by them.

After many weeks of silence from her family, they suddenly called her back to the family without giving her any explanations.

Min Li knew that this was about her failure to recruit Yuan to their family, as news of Yuan's departure from the sect had spread shortly after he left, so it was clear to the Min Family that she had failed to secure him.

"But to think they'd immediately give me to another family... I didn't think they'd move so fast— be willing to toss me away so easily. They must be really upset about my failure..." Min Li sighed again after realizing just how little her family valued her.

While it is true that she lacked in talents and achievements when compared to her siblings, she is still a cultivation genius with a rare talent. How can the Min Family throw her away this easily? She couldn't understand it.

"I don't know when Disciple Yuan will come, so I cannot wait for him to rescue me. Therefore, I will have to deal with this situation by myself. If worst comes to worst, I will climb the Stairway to Heaven by myself! Even if I die in the process, it will be a much better fate than marrying into the Gu Family!"

While Min Li planned her escape from the Min Family and her marriage, Yuan and the others approached their living quarters.

"I'm not sure where the Young Lady is located, but she should be here. Let me go speak with someone for more information." The guard said to them after they arrived.

"Thank you." Yuan nodded.

"Please wait here for a few minutes." The guard then left the place.

Once the guard left, he immediately ran to the Min Family to notify them of the situation.

"What? Madam Feng from the Golden Phoenix Bazaar is here? Why?" The head of the Min Family, Min Yide asked the guard.

Chapter 634 - The Real Madam Feng

"Apparently, her 'Young Master' is here to meet with Young Lady Min Li." The guard responded to Min Yide's question.

"Young Master?" Min Yide suddenly burst out laughing after hearing the guard's words.

"Are you sure she's the real Madam Feng? First of all, Madam Feng left the Golden Phoenix Bazaar a while ago and hasn't been seen since then. Why would she suddenly show up here for Min Li?"

"And her 'Young Master'? I know Madam Feng very well! There's no way that she'd lower herself for another individual! She's a fake! A fake, I tell you!" Min Yide continued laughing.

"Then what about the Royal Guest Medallion?" The guard asked.

"Did anyone verify if it was real or fake?"

"N-No... It would've been disrespectful to Madam Feng, as verifying the medallion is akin to doubting her credibility..." The guard shook his head.

"Just kick them out."

Although he had a bad feeling about Min Yide's orders, the guard didn't dare to disobey him.

"As you command! Please excuse this subordinate!"

The guard quickly returned to Yuan and the others to notify them of Min Yide's response.

"I'm sorry, but you'll have to leave this place now."

"What?" Yuan looked at him with wide eyes.

Didn't he leave to get information on Min Li's location? How did it end up getting them kicked out?"Is this a joke?" Feng Yuxiang stared at the guard with a deep frown on her face, looking like she was on the verge of attacking him for making such a joke.

"I am not joking. The head of the family, Min Yide, has ordered you all to leave this place as soon as possible." The guard repeated.

"Min Yide, huh? When did this bastard become so daring? Let me speak with him!"

"That won't be possible..."

"I am not asking you. I am telling you." Feng Yuxiang suddenly released her Spirit Grandmaster cultivation base, instantly terrifying the guard who was a mere Spirit Warrior.

"S-Spirit Grandmaster! You're the real Madam Feng?!" The guard fell to his buttocks from shock.

"Huh? What nonsense are you talking about? Of course I am real!"

The guard immediately got onto his knees and began kowtowing to her.

"Please forgive this disrespectful junior for mistaking Madam Feng as a fake!"

And in order to save himself a little face, the guard explained to them that Min Yide was the one who told him that she was fake.

"Hmph! Bring me to him!" Feng Yuxiang coldly snorted afterward.

"R-Right away!"

The guard no longer dared to delay things and immediately brought Feng Yuxiang and the others to meet Min Yide.

"Family Head! M-Madam Feng— she's here to see you!" The guard knocked on his door and shouted from the outside.

"I told you to kick out that fake! How dare you come back here with her?! Are you begging to get fired?!" Min Yide's angry voice quickly resounded.

Bang!

Feng Yuxiang suddenly kicked down the door before walking inside the room with a domineering aura around her.

"I dare you to call me a fake again, Min Yide!" Feng Yuxiang stared at Min Yide, who was sitting behind his desk with a gawking face.

"Y-Y-You?! Impossible!"

"Impossible, your mother! Look at my face and tell me I am a fake again!" Feng Yuxiang then retrieved the Royal Guest Medallion and tossed it at Min Yide.

"Look at that medallion and tell me it's fake! I dare you!"

Min Yide held the medallion with trembling hands.

'I-It's real! She's the real Madam Feng!' Min Yide felt his heart drop all the way to his stomach when he realized this fact.

"You know, with the amount of discount I gave your family, I expected to be treated with some respect at the very least. I have done business with your Min Family for thousands of years, giving you billions of gold coins in discounts, yet I am treated like trash when I visit your family. If your ancestors were here, I wonder what they'll say..." Feng Yuxiang sighed out loud.

"P-Please forgive me, Madam Feng! I really thought you were a fake!" Min Yide quickly got onto his knees without caring for his image as the head of the Min Family.

And he continued, "I will accept any punishment from you! Please! Let me apologize to you properly!"

"Then tell me where Min Li is located so that my Young Master can speak with her." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Right away! Please, follow me! I will take you to her!" Min Yide quickly stood up and began walking towards the door.

"Let's go, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang then said to him.

Yuan nodded and followed Min Yide to where they were keeping Min Li.

When they arrived, Feng Yuxiang sneered in a cold voice, "A confinement formation? Are you keeping a prisoner inside this room or something?"

"A-Actually, Min Li is currently grounded and being disciplined for failing an important mission, and in order to prevent her from running away, we placed her inside." Min Yide made up a random excuse.

"Mission? What kind of mission?" Feng Yuxiang asked, acting ignorant about the situation.

"W-Well... It's a very sensitive subject..." Min Yide said, trying to tell her that he doesn't want to talk about it in the vaguest way possible.

"Whatever." Feng Yuxiang shrugged, as she was already aware of the situation.

Min Yide knocked on the door a moment later and said, "Min Li! You have a visitor!"

Min Li, who has been staring outside the window with a dazed face, turned to look at the door after hearing her father's voice.

'Visitor? The Gu Family?' Min Li's initial thought was that the Gu Family had come to visit her. After all, who else could possibly visit her during such a time?

The door opened a moment later without Min Li doing anything, and Yuan calmly entered the room the next second.

"E-Eh...? D-Disciple Yuan? Is that really you?" Min Li's eyes widened with shock the instant she saw his handsome face, and she immediately wondered if she had accidentally dozed off into dreamland, hence the current situation that shouldn't be possible.

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Chapter 635 - Leaving The Min Family

"Haha... I must be dreaming. There's no way he'd be here." Min Li released a low laugh before shaking her head and returning to staring outside the window.

"Who's dreaming?" Yuan asked her.

"..."

After a moment of silence, Min Li turned to look at him again, her eyes wider than before.

"A-Are you real? Am I not asleep? Are you really Disciple Yuan?" Min Li asked for confirmation.

"Why are you still calling me Disciple Yuan? I am no longer a disciple of the Dragon Essence Temple. Just call me Yuan, Disciple Min." Yuan said with a gentle smile on his face.

And he continued, "Also, I am here to fulfill my promise."

Min Li's body visibly trembled when she heard his words.

Meanwhile, Min Yide stared at Yuan from the side with a look of disbelief on his face.

'Y-Yuan? He can't be! Impossible!' Min Yide refused to believe that he was the same 'Yuan' who dominated the Mystic Realm—the same Yuan that they have been desperately trying to recruit.

'Why is he here?! I thought Min Li failed to recruit him!' Min Yide cried inwardly.

"Dis— Yuan!" Min Li jumped out of her seat and pounced at him with her arms wide open, embracing him tightly when she was close enough.

"You really returned for me! I thought you wouldn't make it!"

"I made a promise to you, after all."

"..." Min Yide watched as his youngest child embrace the current number one genius in the Lower Heavens with intimacy, his eyes and mouth as wide as saucers.

"W-What is going on here...?" Min Yide mumbled in a low voice after snapping out of his daze.

Yuan turned to look at him and spoke in a calm voice, "I promised Min Li that I'd climb the Stairway to Heaven for her, so she might not be able to attend the marriage. Do you have any problems with it?"

"Hmph! I never even agreed to this marriage in the first place! They tricked me into returning home and locked me in this room for the past week! All because I failed to recruit you into the family!" Min Li coldly snorted.

"I kind of figured that was the case." Yuan sighed.

He then turned to look at Min Yide and said, "Forcing your children to do something so ridiculous and then punishing her with even more ridiculousness... If this is how the Min Family operates, I do not wish to join it."

Min Yide subconsciously opened his mouth to make some kind of excuse, but he ultimately decided to remain silent, as he was certain that they'd lost all hope in recruiting Yuan to their family.

'If only we treated Min Li better... If only we waited just a little longer...'
Min Yide sighed inwardly.

He then said, "What about the Gu Family? They have long been spreading news of your marriage with Gu Tao. If you don't show up for the wedding, it will not only ruin our reputation, but we'll also be a laughing stock for years to come."

"Hell, the Gu Family, our closest ally, will most likely cut all connection with us afterward."

Feng Yuxiang suddenly sneered and said, "That is not our problem to solve but your Min Family's problem, as you were the ones that dug this hole."

Once again Min Yide opened his mouth only to close it a few seconds later without actually uttering a single word.

However, before he could even ponder about the situation, a guard suddenly showed up and announced, "Family Head, the Gu Family is here to visit. Gu Tao is also with them."

"Aiya! Why do they have to show up now of all times?! They didn't even notify us before visiting!" Min Yide sighed out loud.

Although Min Yide found the Gu Family's presence to be nothing but an annoyance, Yuan actually thought this was a good chance for them to break off the marriage.

"Why don't we use this chance to call off the marriage?" Yuan decided to share his idea.

"What?! We can't!" Min Yide subconsciously responded without thinking.

"The marriage won't happen regardless if you tell them today or a week from now, so you might as well get it out of the way now before they continue spreading news of a marriage that won't happen." Feng Yuxiang said.

Min Yide gritted his teeth.

He turned to look at Min Li and spoke in a solemn voice, "Are you sure you want to do this? If you call off this engagement, you'll no longer be part of

the Min Family."

"Yes, I am sure." Min Li answered without hesitation.

Min Yide closed his eyes and took a few deep breaths.

"Get out of my face. You're officially disowned from the Min Family, Min Li."

After saying that, Min Yide left the scene with the guard to meet with the unsuspecting Gu Family.

Once Min Yide left, Min Li fell onto her knees as her legs suddenly lost all of their strength. This was her first time standing up to her own family.

Yuan wiped the tears that were forming on the edge of her eyes and said, "Let's go to the Stairway to Heaven, shall we?"

"Un!" Min Li nodded, trying her best to resist from crying.

While Yuan and Min Li began making their way out of the Min Family, Min Yide met up with the Gu Family in the living room.

"Is that a face you should be greeting your guests with, Min Yide? You look like you just swallowed a bug! Hahaha!" The Family Head of the Gu Family laughed out loud when he saw Min Yide's face, completely oblivious of the situation.

"Senior Min! Where is Min Li? I'd like to meet her!" The handsome young man standing behind the family head asked.

He was clearly Gu Tao, Min Li's fiancé.

Min Yide took a deep breath before responding in a solemn voice, "Min Li is not here— she has abandoned the Min Family."

"W-What?" The Gu Family stared at him with baffled expressions, seemingly unable to comprehend the situation at first, and the place turned dead silent very quickly.

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Chapter 636 - Golden Dragon Realm

"Let me repeat myself just in case you missed it..." Min Yide cleared his throat and continued.

"Min Li has left the Min Family, so she is no longer part of our family. I'm sorry, but we will have to cancel the wedding between Min Li and Gu Tao," he said, speaking in a clearer tone this time.

Once they snapped out of their daze, Gu Tao screamed loudly, "Bullsh*t! I am not going to cancel the wedding! Where did she go?! I will bring her back myself if I have to!"

"My son is right, Min Yide. We have already expended too many resources on this wedding, and news of the wedding has already spread everywhere. If we cancel it now, both of our families be laughingstocks for the rest of the century! Do you really want that to happen?!"

Min Yide merely sighed at their words and said, "I understand your feelings and anger, but there is truly nothing I can do in this situation. As for bringing her back... That's also not possible."

"Nonsense! Tell me where she is and I will bring her back even if it's by force!" Gu Tao shouted.

Min Yide glared at Gu Tao for a moment before responding in a low voice, "Stairway to Heaven... If you really want to bring her back, you can find her at the Stairway to Heaven. However, don't say I didn't warn you. You really don't want to offend them."

"Them? Who are you talking about? And why on earth would she be going to the Stairway to Heaven? She's only a Spirit Warrior!" The head of the Gu Family frowned.

However, Min Yide turned around and began walking away, "I wish you the best of luck. Once again, I apologize for this inconvenience."

"This isn't over yet, Min Yide!"

The Gu Family left the place shortly after, and they were still fuming in anger after they left.

"Are we going to go to the Stairway to Heaven now?" Gu Tao asked his father.

"Obviously! We cannot let this marriage end in such a ridiculous manner! We are bringing her back even if we have to drag her back!"

Thus, the Gu Family began making their way to the Stairway to Heaven instead of going home, still unaware of the full situation.

Meanwhile, after leaving the Min Family, Min Li asked Yuan, "Are we heading straight to the Stairway to Heaven right now?"

"Actually, there's still one more place I want to visit before leaving the Lower Heavens," he said.

"The Pang City."

"Eh? Why that place? If I remember correctly, that is just a small city with no significance." Min Li said.

Hearing her question, Yuan retrieved the Starry Abyss and said, "This Starry Abyss was given to me by them, and it has been very useful to me, so I want to thank them before leaving. Also, I promised to eat with them again."

"I-Is that so..."

Thus, Yuan and the others began making their way towards Pang City.

On their way there, Yuan received a couple of sudden notifications.

Ding!

[Xuan Wuhan has been added to your Bond!]

[Xuan Wuhan's Bond level has increased to Acquaintance!]

[Xuan Wuhan's Bond level has increased to Friend!]

[Xuan Wuhan's Bond level has increased to Intimate!]

[Congratulations! Your Bond level with Xuan Wuhan has reached Intimate!]

[You have gained the following effect from Xuan Wuhan's Bond level: 'Xuan Wuhan's Adoration']

[Xuan Wuhan's Adoration: Increases your Overall Damage by 30%]

[Fei Yuyan has been added to your Bond!]

[Fei Yuyan's Bond level has increased to Acquaintance!]

[Fei Yuyan's Bond level has increased to Friend!]

[Fei Yuyan's Bond level has increased to Intimate!]

[Congratulations! Your Bond level with Fei Yuyan has reached Intimate!]

[You have gained the following effect from Fei Yuyan's Bond level: 'Fei Yuyan's Adoration']

[Fei Yuyan's Adoration: Increases your Charm by 20 and Zither Mastery by 50%]

['Dragon Essence Temple' has been added to your Associations!]

[Because of your accomplishments, the Dragon Essence Temple has managed to return to its former glory! Your relationship with 'Dragon Essence Temple' has increased tremendously!]

[Due to your accomplishments in the 'Dragon Essence Temple', your Fame has increased by 200!]

[Your relationship with Dragon Essence Temple has reached the maximum level!]

[Due to your relationship with the Dragon Essence Temple, you have gained access to the Golden Dragon Realm!]

'Golden Dragon Realm? What kind of place is that and how do I access it?' Yuan pondered to himself as they moved closer and closer to the Pang City.

A few hours later, they arrived at Pang City.

'I wonder if anything has changed since I left...' Yuan wondered to himself as they approached the guards at the city entrance.

"Hm?" The guards quickly noticed Yuan because of his exquisite Golden Dragon Robe and the beauties by his side.

"What a lucky bastard, surrounded by beauties on all sides..."

"Right? Hm? Wait a second... He looks familiar..."

"W-Wait! That's—!"

It took a couple of moments, but the guards recognized Yuan.

"It's the hero! Our Pang City's hero is back!" The guards began celebrating for some reason.

Yuan raised his eyebrows when he saw the guards that had been guarding the gates suddenly leave their post to run in their direction.

"Hero! Welcome back to Pang City, Hero!" The guards began waving and shouting at him once they were in range.

"What the?" Yuan was baffled by their weird behavior.

Once they were in front of Yuan, the guards suddenly kneeled on the ground, which baffled him even further.

"What are you guys doing?" Yuan asked them.

"Hero! Please! We— the Pang City requires your help again!"

"Please save us, Hero!"

The guards cried out loud in a pleading manner.

"What?"

Although Yuan was still confused about the situation, he could feel an ominous aura in the air.

"What happened?" He asked them with a deep frown on his face.

"It would be for the best if the Luo Family explains it to you. Please, follow me."

Yuan nodded, "Take me to the Luo Family immediately."

Chapter 637 - The Hero Has Returned!

"Lord Luo! The Hero has returned! I repeat, the Hero has returned!"

A guard came rushing into Lord Luo's room without knocking.

"Hero? What nonsense are you talking about? We are having an important discussion right now! Scram!" Lord Luo got angry when his important meeting was interrupted, not to mention the grave situation that has been stressing him lately.

"Sorry for interrupting your meeting, but I heard you need some help, so I came."

Yuan entered the room a few moments later.

However, because of how drastically different his appearance was compared to his last visit, especially his longer hair, Lord Luo didn't recognize Yuan at first.

"Y-You are—!"

Once Lord Luo got a good look at Yuan's handsome face, his body immediately began shivering from sheer excitement, and he even began crying.

"D-Daoist Yuan! Is that really you, Daoist Yuan?!" Lord Luo couldn't control his emotions and spoke as though he was before his savior.

"You have changed— grown so much in just a few months! I almost didn't recognize you!"

"It's really me," Yuan confirmed with a gentle nod.

Then he continued, "Can you tell me what's troubling you and the city? If there's anything I can do to help..."

"Please take a seat first—" Lord Luo suddenly stopped talking when he finally noticed the four beauties standing behind Yuan.

He turned to look at the table only to realize that there was not enough room for everyone.

However, he promptly made a decision and said to the people sitting down, "Stand up and let these esteemed guests sit!"

"It's okay, we can stand." Yuan shook his head.

The people that had already begun leaving their seats froze, and they turned to look at Lord Luo.

"If you say so, Daoist Yuan." Lord Luo nodded before telling the others to get back in their seats.

After sitting down and taking a deep breath, Lord Luo spoke, "Daoist Yuan, have you heard of the Blood Sect?"

"The Blood Sect?" Yuan found this name very familiar for some reason, but he couldn't instantly recall where he'd heard it.

"Young Master, the Blood Sect is one of the top evil sects in this world. Their disciples practice dangerous and forbidden cultivation techniques that people don't practice for obvious reasons, which more often than not causes their disciples to go crazy or become bloodthirsty, and when that happens, they cause havoc in the cultivation world." Feng Yuxiang gave him a brief explanation.

'Ah, I remember now... The Sect Master of the Flying Sword Sect mistook me as a disciple from that place...' Yuan finally recalled what occurred really early on in his journey in this world.

"What about the Blood Sect? Are they causing trouble in this city?" Yuan then asked.

"No, they're not— at least not yet." Lord Luo sighed.

"Not yet? What do you mean by that? Are you expecting trouble?"

Lord Luo nodded and said, "Ever since the Blood Sect's most talented disciple— who is also their Sect Master's only son disappeared mysteriously, they have been doing all sorts of crazy things, such as attacking people randomly."

"And after many months of investigation, they announced his son dead. I heard the Blood Sect's Sect Master had grieved over his son's death so much that he went insane."

Yuan raised his eyebrow when he heard this information, and he proceeded to ask, "What's the name of this person who suddenly went missing?"

"Meng Li— also known as Devil Meng Li." Lord Luo replied.

Yuan subconsciously turned to look at Xiao Hua, who was calmly standing beside him.

He recalled this name very clearly, as he'd learned the Bloody Sword Strike from this person after watching him fight another expert!

However, these two experts had perished under the hands of Xiao Hua! In other words, Xiao Hua holds some responsibility for this mess!

Knowing this information, Yuan felt a little obligated to deal with the situation.

"The Blood Sect had been attacking cities and even sects at random for the past month. Many people have suffered— died because of them. Their most recent victim was the Flying Sword Sect, who they completely destroyed, and judging by their movement patterns, they will most likely attack this city soon."

"W-Wait a second... Did you just say the Flying Sword Sect?" Yuan's eyes widened with shock and disbelief after hearing their name.

This was the first sect that he'd visited in this world! And his friend, Mo Zhou, was a disciple there!

"What happened to the Flying Sword Sect?!" Yuan asked with a deep frown on his face.

"They are gone. Completely vanquished. It was a brutal slaughter. Over half of their disciples were killed, and even their Sect Master died trying to defend his sect. However, what can a single Spirit Master do against the Blood Sect that has multiple Spirit Masters?"

Yuan gritted his teeth and tightened his hands into a fist after learning the situation.

'I lost another friend...'

"Brother Yuan...? Are you okay?" Xiao Hua asked him when she noticed killing intent coming from his aura.

"Why...?" Yuan suddenly mumbled.

"Why must they kill innocent people...?"

"They are humans too, right? They aren't demons, so why are they doing this...? Or maybe they are demons disguised as humans..."

Yuan closed his eyes and took a deep breath.

"Feng Feng, where can I find the Blood Sect?" He suddenly asked her.

"Unfortunately, you won't be able to find them, Young Master."

"Why not?"

"Because the Blood Sect is not a traditional sect where they have a set location for their sect. They operate and recruit without any headquarters. In

other words, we cannot find something that doesn't exist."

"Then how do they communicate with each other?"

"They mostly operate with letters and by mouth. This is how they still exist despite having almost the entire world as their enemies. In fact, that's how most evil sects operate in order to stay alive."

"So there is nothing we can do in this situation besides watch them kill innocent people?" Yuan clenched his jaws even tighter.

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Chapter 638 - Visiting The Flying Sword Sect

"Unfortunately, there really isn't much you can do against the Blood Sect. Even if you kill their Sect Master, another one will eventually rise to that spot. You can maybe try killing all of the higher-ups in the Blood Sect, but that is easier said than done. There's a reason they have existed for thousands of years despite countless experts trying to wipe them out." Feng Yuxiang said to him.

Yuan pondered about Feng Yuxiang's words. If he cannot do anything against the Blood Sect, what should he do about Pang City's situation? It was not as though he could give up and abandon them.

After thinking for a moment, Yuan turned to look at Lord Luo and said, "Do you mind if I stay here for a few days? I will try to come up with a solution, and just in case they attack."

"Of course! You can stay here for as long as you want!" Lord Luo immediately said.

Suddenly, one of the people there said, "I'm sorry, but what can you do against the Blood Sect?"

"The Blood Sect has multiple Spirit Masters, and their Sect Master is also a Spirit Grandmaster. Not even an entire sect can stop them, much less a couple of young people. I say we evacuate the city and seek protection from one of the bigger sects such as the Heaven and Earth Palace or the Grand Sword Mountain."

Everyone there turned to look at Yuan for a response, even Lord Luo, who had immense faith in him, cannot imagine a Spirit Warrior defending against the Blood Sect.

Of course, he was not aware that Yuan had become a Spirit Grandmaster during the few months he was gone.

"It's just a few Spirit Masters. My Young Master can handle even a Spirit Lord, much less a Spirit Grandmaster." Feng Yuxiang suddenly sneered.

"W-What? A Spirit Lord?"

Yuan then released his Spirit Grandmaster aura and said, "I alone can defend the city from the Blood Sect."

"S-S-Spirit Grandmaster?! How is that possible?! You were only a Spirit Warrior before you left a few months ago!" Lord Luo exclaimed.

"What?! A Spirit Warrior?!" The others were also shocked.

"Don't even bother thinking about it. My Young Master's talents are incomprehensible." Feng Yuxiang said to them.

Yuan continued, "I am not the only Spirit Grandmaster. These two are also Spirit Grandmasters."

He pointed to Feng Yuxiang and Lan Yingying.

"Three Spirit Grandmasters!"

Lord Luo immediately got onto his knees and said, "This junior apologizes for not greeting these seniors earlier!"

The others also followed suit and bowed to them.

In their eyes, Spirit Grandmasters were akin to gods— immortal cultivators that live in a different world.

Yuan raised his eyebrows and said, "What are you guys doing? Hurry up and stand up. We're already far past the greeting stage."

"Anyways, as long as we're here, I promise you that the Blood Sect won't cause any trouble."

"Thank you, Daoist Yuan!" Lord Luo said.

Sometime later, Yuan said, "I am going to the Flying Sword Sect. Feng Feng, Yingying, can you two stay in the city just in case the Blood Sect attacks? I won't be gone for long."

"Why are you going there, Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang couldn't help but ask.

"I am going there to pray for them," he calmly said.

"Don't worry, we'll keep the place safe." Lan Yingying said.

"Thank you."

He turned to look at Min Li and continued, "Sorry, but we'll have to delay our journey for a few days."

Min Li shook her head and said, "You don't have to say anything to me. Even if you delay it for a year, I do not have any rights to complain."

Yuan left the place shortly after with Xiao Hua by his side.

With Yuan gone, Lord Luo felt incredibly anxious with two Spirit Grandmasters that he wasn't familiar with acting as guards there.

"Hey." Feng Yuxiang suddenly looked at Lord Luo, who trembled upon feeling her gaze.

"Y-Yes!" He stood up and responded in a stiff manner.

"Calm down, I won't eat you or anything. Anyways, can you tell me about the Young Master's relationship with this city? I would like to know more

about him."

"I'd also like that as well." Lan Yingying agreed.

Lord Luo nodded, and he proceeded to recall how Yuan protected their city from the Mountain Lord's invasion.

After he finished telling them the story, two more people showed up in the room, and they were Luo Li and Luo Ling, Lord Luo's daughters.

"Father! I heard that Brother Yuan had returned to the city! Where is he?!" They immediately began inquiring about Yuan.

Seeing these two pretty ladies, Feng Yuxiang raised her eyebrows and asked, "Who are you?"

"They are my daughters, Esteemed Senior." Lord Luo said.

"Luo Li! Luo Ling! Hurry up and greet the Seniors!" He then said to the two.

"But what about Brother Yuan? We didn't come here for them!" Luo Ling said, unaware that they were Spirit Grandmasters.

"Insolence!" Lord Luo immediately became angry.

Feng Yuxiang raised her hand to stop Lord Luo, and she said to the sisters, "Tell me about your relationship with the Young Master and I will tell you his location."

The sisters exchanged looks with each other. Young Master? When did Yuan obtain such a beautiful woman as his servant?

Luo Ling, the older sister, stepped forward and said in a proud voice, "We're his future concubines!"

And she added a second later, "...Hopefully!"

Although Yuan never officially accepted them as his concubines, Luo Ling didn't think too much about her response since she was only responding to a mere 'servant'.

"What?!" Feng Yuxiang's eyes widened with shock.

"T-They are only joking with you, Esteemed Seniors..." Lord Luo quickly said.

He then turned to look at his daughters and frowned, "They are Spirit Grandmasters! Watch your language!"

"What?!" The sisters' eyes widened with shock after learning this information.

They then got on their knees and apologized for their behavior.

Meanwhile, Yuan and Xiao Hua arrived at the Flying Sword Sect— at least what it once used to be.

Chapter 639 - Insanity

"T-This is the Flying Sword Sect...?" Yuan stood before where the sect should have been located with a clear look of disbelief on his face.

However, the Flying Sword Sect was nowhere to be seen. Instead, destroyed buildings and dried blood scattered the place.

"The scenery is what it would look like after a long and brutal war had just finished..." Yuan mumbled in a low voice.

"Thousands of lives perished here for what? What does the Blood Sect achieve by doing this horrible thing? It won't bring back their Sect Master's dead son."

"Unfortunately, this is the harsh reality of the cultivation world—the real cultivation world, where people do unreasonable things, and there's nothing we can do about it." Xiao Hua sighed.

"..."

After a moment of silence, Yuan said, "Let's take a look around this place."

"Are you sure, Brother Yuan? There will be a lot of blood and corpses. It won't be a pretty sight."

Yuan nodded, "Even so, I want to see it."

They proceeded to walk around the unrecognizable and destroyed Flying Sword Sect, passing by many corpses and separated body parts.

Yuan stopped walking in front of three large stone tablets, which were the only things not completely destroyed there.

He looked at the stone tablet in the middle, and on the very top, there was a name he was familiar with.

"Mo Zhou... So you have managed to become rank one, huh? Congratulations..." Yuan congratulated him in a dispirited voice.

He then clasped his hands together and bowed to the stone tablet, paying his respects.

"Brother Yuan, there are people around us." Xiao Hua suddenly said.

"The Blood Sect?" Yuan asked.

"Probably not. They are all Spirit Apprentices," she said.

"Why would they be here?"

"When a sect is destroyed, it is common for people to try and salvage everything they can find. These people hope to be lucky and find valuable things such as cultivation techniques and treasures."

Yuan frowned, "An entire sect is destroyed and these people are in the mood to look for treasures? Do they have no respect at all?"

"Most people doing this have nothing to lose, and finding even a single cultivation technique could change their lives forever. There would usually be more people. It's probably because of the Blood Sect's presence. Nobody wants to run into them, after all."

Hearing Xiao Hua's explanation, Yuan merely shook his head in silence. Although he cannot blame these people for wanting a better life, it still leaves a bad taste in his mouth.

Suddenly, a loud scream resounded.

"AHHHH! HELP! THE BLOOD SECT IS HERE!"

Yuan immediately turned to look in the direction of the voice, and without hesitation, started running towards the voice.

A few moments later, Yuan arrived before a group of individuals being surrounded by these people that were fully cloaked in black robes with black masks covering their faces.

"Please! Spare us!"

The individuals being surrounded got onto their knees and began begging for their lives.

However, the masked cultivators responded by drawing their weapons.

When Yuan saw this, he shouted, "Stop!"

Whoosh!

Yuan's Spirit Grandmaster cultivation base exploded, instantly halting the masked cultivators and forcing them onto their knees just like those surrounded.

"W-Who are you?! Do you have any idea who we are?!" One of the masked figures shouted at Yuan, but he was clearly terrified.

"The Blood Sect, right?" Yuan responded in a calm voice.

"Hmph! If you already know, then let us go! Unless you want the entire Blood Sect to hunt you down!" The masked figure sneered.

"Let you go...? So you can kill more innocent people? I'd rather be hunted than let you kill more innocent people!" Yuan looked at them with an angry frown on his face.

"Tell me! Why did you destroy the Flying Sword Sect?! Why did you kill all these innocent disciples?!"

"Why? Why not? They were weak and unfortunate, so they were targeted by Lord Blood. We're only following our orders," said one of them in an indifferent voice.

"And you followed such ridiculous orders?! What do you achieve from it besides guilt and blood on your hands?!"

"Hah! Guilt? What kind of nonsense is that? We don't regret our actions! In fact, we enjoyed every moment of it! Killing these weak disciples and being covered in their blood— it makes my body shiver just thinking about it! This is why we joined the Blood Sect!"

"You're all insane..." Yuan was left speechless by this individual's lack of humanity.

"Brother Yuan, you should save your breath and just kill them all already. Everyone in evil sects is like this— bloodthirsty and insane." Xiao Hua said to him.

Yuan gritted his teeth and clenched his hands into fists.

Despite all the horrible things they have done, he still hesitates on killing them. After all, they are not just mere NPCs but real people. If he kills them, that would be akin to killing a real human, and he has never even thought about killing another human before!

Seeing his hesitation, Xiao Hua continued to speak, "Brother Yuan, it's okay to kill these kinds of people. The world will be better off without them, too. If you don't kill them, they will just go on and kill other innocent people."

"When that happens... You'll also bear the guilt of their death since you allowed it to happen by not killing these evil cultivators..."

Hearing Xiao Hua's words, Yuan felt less hesitant on killing them.

However, before he could make up his mind, a familiar voice suddenly resounded inside his head.

"Why are you hesitating? They are just a couple of useless ants. You can kill them as easily as breathing. I know you want to kill them. Let me show you..."

Yuan suddenly closed his eyes.

Once he reopened them, his eyes were resolute and filled with killing intent, and they were even slightly glowing red.

The Empyrean Overlord appeared in his hand the next moment.

"W-What do you think you're doing?! Our Sect Master is a Spirit Grandmaster! He'll kill you as easy as breathing!" The Blood Sect disciples began shivering uncontrollably as they watched Yuan slowly approach them with a sadistic grin on his face.

"As a killer, you should know very well what I am about to do, right?" Yuan responded, his aura gushing with killing intent.

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Chapter 640 - Killing Each Other

"S-Stop! Let us go! Our Blood Sect will hunt you and your nine generations down if you harm us!" The Blood Sect disciples shouted.

Yuan stopped walking once he was in front of these people, and he took a long and deep breath.

A strong smell of blood and corpses immediately assaulted his nose.

"Haaaa..."

He released a long sigh before speaking, "You know, I don't blame you for killing people. It's the nature of cultivators, after all. However, if you're going to kill someone, you better have a damn good reason."

After this sentence, Yuan suddenly lifted the Empyrean Overlord and pointed it at one of the Blood Sect disciples.

"And killing these disciples for your own entertainment is not a good reason... This is why I despise evil sects. You guys are a bunch of boring individuals."

The Blood Sect disciple being pointed at suddenly felt a sharp pain coming from his throat, but he was too scared of Yuan's cold gaze to move, not to mention the pressure restricting his body, so he wasn't sure what was causing this pain.

However, the other Blood Sect disciples saw it clearly. Yuan was slowly pushing the tip of his sword into their fellow disciple's throat, penetrating the skin on his neck with no resistance like it was tofu.

"Stop! Are you really not afraid of the Blood Sect?! Our fellow disciples will definitely avenge us and hunt you down!" They began shouting.

"Hunt me? Hahaha!" Yuan moved the sword an inch forward, causing blood to flow from the disciple's neck.

He then spoke while continuing to push the sword deeper into the disciple's throat, "How will the Blood Sect learn of this if I kill all of you? How will you tell them? As a ghost?"

By the time Yuan finished his sentence, the sword was already halfway through the disciple's neck.

Of course, the disciple was already dead at this stage, but Yuan didn't retrieve his sword and continued to push his sword forward until the disciple's head was completely separated from his body.

After decapitating the disciple, Yuan swung his leg, kicking the decapitating head as though it was a ball, shocking everyone there.

The head flew so far that it disappeared into the horizon.

Yuan then turned to look at the rest of the disciples and said with a grin, "Maybe I should let one of you live so that you can avenge your friends."

"The question is... which of you will live?"

"Y-You're insane...!" The disciples were in disbelief.

Yuan suddenly lifted the pressure restricting them and said, "I have an idea. Why don't you fight each other to death? The last one to remain standing will get to live for another day."

"Fuck you! As if we'd listen to you!"

When the disciples felt the pressure disappear, one of them immediately tried running away.

However, before he could go very far, his body would suddenly stop moving when a hole suddenly appeared in the center of his face.

"W-What happened?!"

The others were shocked to see this. No, it was because they couldn't see what had killed him that shocked them.

When they returned to looking at Yuan, they noticed something new.

There was a beautiful black dagger flying beside him.

"You can try to run, but I highly doubt you'll be faster than my flying dagger," Yuan said to them in a nonchalant voice.

"If we can't run, we'll just kill you!"

"Brothers! Let's fight him together!"

Yuan laughed upon hearing their words, "What can you ants do against me?"

The disciples then watched as Yuan start flying towards the sky.

"H-He's a Spirit Grandmaster?!"

The disciples were shocked to see him fly. They were only Spirit Warriors, so they didn't know his real cultivation base until now. Furthermore, they assumed that he was a Spirit Master at most because of his young appearance.

Now that they were aware of Yuan's cultivation, all of the hope and viciousness in their eyes disappeared.

"I will give you all one last chance. Either you fight each other to death and have a chance to survive, or I kill you all right here and now." Yuan spoke as he gazed down on them from the sky like a god.

The Blood Sect disciples gritted their teeth.

They then silently looked at each other with resolute faces.

"Don't blame me for this!"

"Die for me!"

The Blood Sect disciples began fighting each other the next moment.

If they were ordinary cultivators, they might have resisted a little more, but these people were evil cultivators.

They were selfish and bloodthirsty people. Even though they were part of the same sect, it was common for them to kill each other, as the saying 'the strong rules the weak' is even more prominent in evil sects, and there was no rule that prevented them from killing each other.

"Hahaha! That's it! Kill each other!" Yuan laughed out loud in the sky.

"Brother Yuan..." Xiao Hua looked at Yuan with a worried look on her face, feeling as though she was looking at an entirely different individual.

"Hm?" Yuan turned to look at Xiao Hua when he noticed her gaze.

"!!!"

When Xiao Hua saw Yuan's cold and sinister gaze, she began trembling in fear, as he reminded her of someone.

'Father...'

Yuan noticed the fear in Xiao Hua's eyes, so he turned back around a moment later and returned to watching the Blood Sect disciples killing each other.

It lasted a few minutes, but eventually, only one of them remained.

"I have won! Are you going to let me go now, or will you go back on your words and kill me too?!" The Blood Sect disciple shouted at Yuan.

"I won't go back on my own words. You're free to go. However, before you leave..."

After a moment of silence, Yuan continued, "Tell your Sect Master that if he wants to avenge his dead son Meng Li to come here in three days. I will be waiting for him."

"W-What...?" The Blood Sect disciple's eyes widened with shock after hearing Yuan's words.

"Y-You're responsible for Meng Li's death?!"

"I guess you can say that..." Yuan smiled calmly.

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Chapter 641 - Hunted By The Blood Sect

"Y-You will regret this!!! You will now be hunted by the entire Blood Sect!"
The Blood Sect disciple disappeared from the scene quickly afterward.

Yuan turned to look at the people that had been treasure hunting before getting caught by the Blood Sect and said to them, "If you don't want to die like them, get out of this place."

"Y-Yes! Thank you, Senior!"

They quickly left the scene as well.

Once Yuan was alone with Xiao Hua, the place became dead silent.

Yuan closed his eyes for a moment.

When he opened them again, his eyes were no longer vicious but innocent, and his entire demeanor changed.

Yuan looked at the corpses in front of him, as well as the decapitated body with a perplexing emotion in his heart.

After standing there in silence for a few moments, he turned around and said to Xiao Hua, "Let's go back for now..."

Xiao Hua quietly nodded and followed him.

The entire journey back to Pang City was a quiet one with neither of them starting a conversation.

While they walked, Yuan pondered inwardly, 'That person was neither the Demon Sealing Clan's Founder nor the other two, so who was he? Could it be another one of my reincarnations?'

'No... I have seen him before...'

Yuan suddenly recalled the bloody dream he had when he got his faction symbol after joining the Celestial Overlords.

'Could it be him? His demeanor and aura felt just like that person... Just who is he?'

Now he wondered if he was a murderer in one of his past life, as he was completely tranquil when killing the Blood Sect disciples, almost like it was natural for him to have blood on his hands.

Once they returned to Pang City, Yuan looked at Xiao Hua and said to her in a low voice, "I'm sorry if I scared you..."

Even though he wasn't in control of his body at that time, just like when the Divine Paragon took control of his body to deal with the demon, it was still his body that did all those things.

"It's okay, Brother Yuan. As long as you're fine," she said with a gentle smile on her face.

Now that Yuan no longer had that terrifying aura around him, she was no longer scared of him.

Of course, she was still curious about why Yuan suddenly had a change of character. It was almost as though he was possessed by a ghost. However, she could tell that he wasn't possessed, which only made it more puzzling.

"Welcome back, Young Master!" Feng Yuxiang greeted Yuan when he returned.

"I'm back."

"D-Daoist Yuan! W-Welcome back!"

"Hmm?"

Yuan turned to look at the two pretty ladies standing behind Lord Luo.

It was Luo Ling and Luo Li.

"Hey, you two. It's been a while." Yuan smiled at them, causing them to blush.

"You have changed a lot..." Luo Li was dazed by his new appearance.

"Just a little."

"No, you're almost unrecognizable, Daoist Yuan!" Luo Ling said.

"Why are you still addressing me as Daoist Yuan? There's no need to be so formal." Yuan quickly noticed their formality towards him.

"W-Well..."

After learning that Yuan had become a Spirit Grandmaster, these sisters no longer dared to treat him so casually.

"Just call me Yuan. I insist."

"Alright, Yuan." Luo Li nodded.

"Welcome back, Yuan. You've returned earlier than I expected."

"I intend on challenging the Stairway to Heaven soon, so I decided to visit you guys before I leave."

"I see... So you'll be leaving the Lower Heavens soon..."

The sisters were sad to hear this, but there wasn't anything they could do about it.

"How was your visit to the Flying Sword Sect, Young Master?" Feng Feng suddenly asked him.

"..."

After a moment of silence, he sighed, "We encountered the Blood Sect."

"You what?! Are you okay?!" Lord Luo immediately asked him in a worried voice.

"I'm fine."

"What happened to the Blood Sect?" Feng Feng then asked.

"Well..." Yuan hesitated to tell them the story, as he was afraid that they might look at him differently afterward.

Seeing Yuan's reaction, Xiao Hua said, "They killed each other."

"What? Why would they do that?" Feng Yuxiang's eyes widened with surprise.

"Because I told them to." Yuan sighed.

"Eh?" Feng Yuxiang looked at him with disbelief on her face.

She cannot imagine Yuan ordering people to kill each other even if they are from the Blood Sect, so what exactly happened at the Flying Sword Sect?

Yuan proceeded to explain the situation to them— how he left one alive so that he could make himself a target and reveal the Sect Master of the Blood Sect, Lord Blood.

"Unbelievable..." Feng Yuxiang mumbled in a low voice, yet she admired his boldness.

'The Young Master is usually really reserved... The Blood Sect must have really angered him to make him do such things,' she thought to herself.

"So you're going to fight the Blood Sect's Sect Master in three days? Do you need our help?" Lan Yingying asked him.

"I should be able to defeat him by myself, and I don't want dirty your hands with their blood," Yuan said.

"Anyways, we can talk more about this later. Right now, I want to clear my mind of the Blood Sect."

Yuan then turned to look at the Luo Sisters and asked them, "Do you want to eat something right now? This is one of the reasons why I returned, too."

The sisters were speechless. How can he still be in the mood to eat while knowing that he's going to be hunted by the Blood Sect?

However, they didn't refuse and nodded their heads, as they have been waiting for this moment ever since he left.

And for the rest of the day, they all went outside to get food, returning to all of the restaurants they have already gone to before, allowing Yuan to temporarily forget about the Blood Sect and the Flying Sword Sect.

Meanwhile, the Blood Sect's Sect Master had just received news of what happened at the Flying Sword Sect, and as one could expect, he was fuming in anger afterward.

"At last! The bastard who killed my son! I have finally found you! If I don't skin him alive and feed his bones to the pigs, I am not surnamed Meng!"

Chapter 642: Half a Year of Supplies

After eating to their full, Yuan and the others returned to the Luo Family's manor.

"Young Master, do you want to temper your body tonight as well?" Feng Yuxiang asked him after they returned.

"That would be ideal." Yuan nodded.

"Just let me know whenever you're ready."

"Okay."

Yuan logged off shortly after to eat dinner, and he would explain to them the situation at the table.

"Because of this evil sect called the Blood Sect that might attack this city, I will be staying in this city for a few more days before we challenge the Stairway to Heaven."

"Sounds troublesome. What do evil sects even do, anyway?" Chu Liuxiang asked.

"I don't know the purpose of their existence. All I know is that they're filled with unreasonable people who kill innocent people for their own entertainment, and they cultivate forbidden techniques that make them go crazy."

Once dinner was finished, Meixiu said, "Yuan, the Cultivators' Association contacted me this afternoon. They said we can visit them whenever because

they have finished scouting for our faction's headquarters."

"Really? We can visit them tomorrow since I have three days before I fight the Blood Sect."

"Alright, I will let them know tomorrow morning."

"Don't forget to tell the other members."

"I won't."

Yuan returned to Cultivation Online for the rest of the night to temper his body with the treasures provided by Feng Yuxiang, who was literally a walking treasure trove just like Xiao Hua but with more variety since Xiao Hua only has weapons.

Before getting into the bathtub, Yuan asked the others, "I feel kind of bad tempering my body alone. Do any of you want to join me? Feng Feng, it's your treasure, so you should..."

"I am fine, Young Master. Don't forget that I have the body of a phoenix, so these treasures won't affect me."

Yuan then looked at Xiao Hua and Lan Yingying.

"Xiao Hua doesn't require body tempering because of her physique," she said to him.

This leaves Lan Yingying, who was silently pondering whether she wants to temper her body or not.

Although she is also a divine beast like Feng Yuxiang, she doesn't have a naturally strong body, so tempering her body would actually benefit her.

"What about you, Yingying? Want to try tempering your body? It'll make your body stronger."

"If you don't mind sharing your treasures with me..."

“Of course I don’t mind sharing. I’m not that selfish, and I don’t even own the treasures.”

“Then I’ll join you.” Lan Yingying nodded her head a moment later.

Sometime later, Yuan entered the bathtub with Lan Yingying, which had just enough room for the two of them.

“Are you okay?” Yuan asked her, feeling Lan Yingying’s smooth back touching his back.

“Yes. Thank you for giving me this opportunity, Lord.” She said.

A bittersweet smile appeared on Yuan’s face, and he said, “I really cannot get used to being called ‘Lord’. Can’t you just call me Yuan like you used to? Please?”

After a moment of silence, Lan Yingying responded, “I understand, Yuan.”

“Thank you.”

The two of them began absorbing the medicine in the bathtub shortly after.

Lan Yingying immediately began sweating when she felt the pain from the medicine, as she has never experienced such intense pain before— not even when she trained with her grandparents.

However, as a divine beast, Lan Yingying’s endurance is naturally higher than humans, so it wasn’t as bad as when Yuan first experienced it.

Two hours later, all of the medicine had been absorbed from the bathtub. There was enough medicine to last four hours, but since there were two of them, it was absorbed twice as fast.

“How do you feel?” Yuan asked Lan Yingying afterward, who was breathing heavily.

“My body hurts all over like I am constantly being pricked by needles, but it’s not unendurable. My skin also feels a lot smoother,” she said.

After getting out of the bathtub, they rinsed their body with clean water before leaving the bathroom fully dressed.

Since they have seen each other naked before, even bathing in a river together, neither of them felt awkward, almost like it was natural.

“Hm? That ended quicker than I anticipated. Looks like I will have to increase the treasures next time.” Feng Yuxiang after seeing them leave the bathroom.

Yuan then said, “Doesn’t it require a lot of treasure to temper one person? Now that you have to deal with two people, you’ll run out of treasures much quicker... Looks like I also need to start gathering my own treasures.”

“It’s not that bad. I have enough treasures to help the Young Master for an entire year. However, now that Yingying will also be tempering her body, that supply will only last half as long, so we still have half a year before I run out of treasures.”

“Half a year...” Yuan nodded and said, “I will figure a way to obtain treasures to temper Yingying and myself before then so that you don’t have to use your treasures on us anymore. I have said this before, but I really feel guilty using your treasures for my own benefit...”

Feng Yuxiang smiled and said, “I have also said this before, but it’s my pleasure to assist you in any way possible. Although these treasures are valuable in the Lower Heavens, they’re not worth much in the upper heavens.”

“Furthermore, I only have them because I had a business to run before. Now that I no longer have a store, nor do I need to sell them, I really have no use for the treasures, so instead of letting them sit in my storage ring forever, I would rather use them to help the Young Master.”

“Thank you, Feng Feng...” Yuan nodded.

And for the remainder of the night, Yuan would cultivate the spiritual energy he'd absorbed from the bath, quickly rising his cultivation base.

The following morning, Yuan logged off and prepared to head to the Cultivators' Association with Meixiu and the others, leaving Pang City's protection to Feng Yuxiang and the other two.

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Chapter 643: Dragon Spiral Mountain

“Hey, Yuan! It’s been a while! How have y’all been?” Wang Ming greeted them with the others behind him.

“Hello, everyone. Everything’s been great on our side. What about you guys?”

“It was very boring since we couldn’t really train in the hotel we were staying at. We’ve been waiting for our own headquarters so that we can train all we want!”

Yuan smiled and said, “Then let’s see what the Cultivators’ Association has in store for us.”

Upon arriving at the Cultivators’ Association, they could see Chairman Lee standing by the entrance, clearly waiting for their arrival.

“Good morning, everyone. Our Cultivators’ Association has managed to find 5 headquarters that fit your requirements, and they’re all in this city. We’ll go look at each of them whenever you’re ready.”

“We can go look at them right now,” Yuan said.

“Very well. Please follow me. We have prepared transportation for you all.”

Yuan and the others followed Chairman Lee to the parking lot, where a long limousine was waiting, and it had more than enough room to fit all 10 of them.

Once they were seated, Chairman Lee got into the driver's seat and personally managed the car, acting as their personal chauffeur despite his status within the Cultivators' Association.

As they began moving, Chairman Lee said, "There should a yellow envelope on the table. You can find information and images of the headquarters we've scouted. Take a look at it if you'd like."

Yuan opened the yellow envelope and took out the papers inside.

"There's only information on four headquarters here. I thought we had 5?" Yuan asked after realizing this.

Chairman Lee laughed and said, "One of them is located in a very special place, so I want to keep it a surprise. However, it's also the most expensive, so we'll look at it last."

About half an hour later, they arrived at the first location, which was a large mansion in the middle of a rich neighborhood.

"There are a few other factions located in this neighborhood if you care about that." Chairman Lee said as he led them to the mansion, which had over 50 rooms available, with half of them being bedrooms.

Yuan was a little impressed by the size of the place, but compared to the Yu Family's main living quarters, it could still be considered 'small'.

"Take your time looking around the place, Daoist Yuan and his friends. I will be here if you need me. By the way, this place costs 50 million." Chairman Lee said to them.

Thus, Yuan and the others began exploring the place as a group.

"There's even a large pool in here."

"This gym is kind of small..."

"Let's check out the backyard next..."

About half an hour later, they finished their exploration.

“What do you guys think of this place?” Yuan asked them afterward.

“It’s a nice place, but I don’t think the atmosphere in this place is fitting for a headquarter. It’s more like a living quarter.” Wang Ming said, and the others agreed.

“There are still four other places to look at.”

They returned to Chairman Lee shortly afterward.

“What do you think of the place?” Chairman Lee asked them.

Yuan gave his feedback.

“I see... No worries if you don’t like it. Let’s head to the next place and hope it’s better.”

Thus, Chairman Lee drove them to the next place, and this would continue for the entire day until they have seen all of the buildings.

“The last place was the best so far, but it’s still lacking something...” Wang Ming said.

“I think so too...”

“It’s alright. We still have one more place to look at, and I can guarantee that it’ll be many times better than the last four.” Chairman Lee said.

“What’s so special about this place?” Shi Lang asked.

Chairman Lee retrieved another envelope and handed it to them before starting the car.

“Dragon Spiral Mountain?” Yuan raised his eyebrows when he saw the name on the envelope.

“That’s right. Your next headquarter will be located in the one and only Dragon Spiral Mountain!” Chairman Lee said.

And he continued, “It wasn’t easy getting this place, you know. Many factions want to go there, but they have all been rejected.”

“I have never heard of this place before,” Yuan said.

“It’s a little bit far, but it’s still within the city. The Dragon Spiral Mountain is a famous place where—”

“It’s where the most powerful families in the world live.” Chu Liuxiang suddenly interrupted Chairman Lee.

“Eh? You know of this place?” Yuan looked at her.

Chu Liuxiang nodded and said, “Of course. My family lives there, after all.”

“What? Your family lives there?” Chairman Lee was shocked to learn this, and he was immediately intrigued about her identity.

The disciples from the Jaded Garden also looked at Chu Liuxiang with pondering gazes. They knew she wasn’t from an ordinary family, but to think she belongs to a family that resides in the Dragon Spiral Mountain.

“Brother Yuan, if you live in the Dragon Spiral Mountain, I will get to visit you whenever I want even if I have to return home.” She said with a smile on her face.

“I would like to meet your family as well.” Yuan nodded.

Chairman Lee then said, “Daoist Yuan, the Dragon Spiral Mountain is also rich with spiritual energy. In fact, it probably has the most spiritual energy in this country.”

“Oh? So something like the immortal caves?”

“That’s right.” Chu Liuxiang nodded, and she continued, “However, it’s even better than the immortal caves, and it’s not restricted to a small area like the Jaded Garden. Furthermore, the higher you live in the mountain, the richer the spiritual energy will be.”

“Now my anticipation for this Dragon Spiral Mountain is very high. I cannot wait to see this place.” Yuan said with a smile.

Three hours later, the car stopped in front of a small but tall mountain that was surrounded by a thick wall. As for the location of the mountain itself, they were in a very secluded area with no other buildings around, almost like they were in the wilderness.

“We have arrived,” Chairman Lee said to them.

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Chapter 644: Four Billion Dollars

“Wow, the dragon in its name is really fitting.” Wang Ming mumbled to himself as he looked through the car window.

The mountain itself wasn’t anything too special, but the road that spirals around the mountain had the appearance of a dragon, making it seem as though there was a dragon coiling around the mountain.

While they admired the mountain, Chairman Lee pulled up to the gates and spoke to the guards there.

“I’m Chairman Lee from the Cultivators’ Association, and I have with me the Demon Sealing Faction. We’re here as scheduled.”

Once the guards verified his identity, they opened the gates to allow them inside.

“Take your time.”

“Thank you.”

The moment they entered the gates, it felt as though they had entered another world, as the spiritual energy suddenly spiked up.

Yuan was pleasantly surprised by this. Although it wasn’t as powerful as the spiritual energy in the immortal caves, they were only at the entrance of the mountain—the lowest level. He can only imagine how much stronger the spiritual energy gets as they go higher into the mountain.

“Where will our headquarters be located?” Shi Lang asked.

“The middle levels. I tried getting you guys a headquarters at the upper levels, but you don’t have even credibility. Don’t be discouraged, though, as you can always move to the upper levels once you’re ready.”

“Furthermore, getting a building in the middle level is already an amazing feat for a new faction with only 10 members.” Chairman Lee said.

Everyone there turned to look at Yuan. Surely, he’s the reason they were allowed to even step foot inside the Dragon Spiral Mountain.

Sometime later, Chairman Lee stopped the car somewhere in the middle level of the Dragon Spiral Mountain.

“Go ahead. Take a look around and tell me what you think.”

Yuan and the others wasted no time and immediately went to look around the place.

“Wow, there are two separate buildings in this place. Is the second one included if we buy the first one?” Wang Ming asked.

“Yes, everything here is included.” Chairman Lee nodded.

The first building, which was also the most spacious, had all sorts of training facilities, indoor sports fields, and offices. As for the second building, it was more of a living quarter than anything, as most of its rooms were bedrooms.

Besides the buildings, there were also a lot of empty lands, outdoor sports fields, an outdoor training area, and even a pond, almost like a miniature Jaded Garden.

“The spiritual energy in this area is slightly above the immortal caves... Unbelievable...” Wang Ming mumbled to himself.

And he continued, “I like this place.”

“I also think we should take this place. It has pretty much everything we need.” Shi Lang agreed.

The others also shared the same sentiment.

Yuan nodded.

“How much is this place?” Yuan then asked Chairman Lee.

“Since this is the Dragon Spiral Mountain, it’s going to be a lot more expensive than your typical house. The total will be 4 billion dollars, and you’ll have to pay 100 million every year for property tax.”

“F-Four billion?!” Yuan was left speechless by this enormous price tag.

Even after selling his Divine-grade treasure, he cannot even afford half of it!

“I only have half a billion...” Yuan sighed.

Chairman Lee then spoke, “You can pay monthly installments if you cannot pay all of it right now. If you need money, our Cultivators’ Association will gladly help—”

“It’s okay, we can pay for it.” Li Jinxi suddenly said, interrupting Chairman Lee.

“You mean our families? Cause we don’t have that kind of money.” Wang Ming said.

Shi Lang nodded and said, “Yuan, you can pay as much as you can afford. Our families will fill in the gap.”

“Are you sure? 3.5 billion is a lot of money.”

“You’re not buying this place for yourself, are you? Since we’re also going to live here, we are obligated to pay our share. It’s only fair that way. And although 3.5 billion is a lot of money, it’s nothing worth mentioning before the Six Spiritual Families.” Wang Ming smiled.

“Then it’s decided. We’ll take this place.” Li Jinxi said to Chairman Lee.

“I-I will let the owner of the mountain know your decision!” Chairman Lee quickly said.

“Hey, Chairman, I’m curious. If the middle-level houses are already this expensive, how much would it cost to live up there?” Hong Xiuquan asked.

Chairman Lee smiled and said, “The houses up there will cost 20 billion at minimum.”

“20 billion?!” They were shocked.

“As expected, only the wealthiest could possibly live in this place.” Shi Lang sighed.

“That’s not true. Even if you are rich, you’re not guaranteed to live in the Dragon Spiral Mountain. Only those approved by the lord of this mountain can live here.” Chairman Lee said.

“Who is the lord?” Yuan asked.

“He’s a very seclusive individual. Even I don’t know his identity.” Chairman Lee shrugged.

“Then how are you going to contact him?”

“He has a manager who does everything for him, and that’s who I speak with.”

“I see...”

“Maybe you’ll get to meet the lord in the future since you’ll be living in his property.”

“To own the entire Dragon Spiral Mountain, I cannot imagine how powerful this person must be.” Wang Ming mumbled.

Sometime later, Chairman Lee said, “Daoist Yuan, I will have the paperwork ready by the time we return to the Cultivators’ Association. You

don't have to pay immediately, but you can start moving in starting today if you'd like."

"Alright. Thank you." Yuan nodded.

He then turned to Chu Liuxiang and asked her, "Lulu, do you want to visit your family since we're already here?"

She shook her head, "No. If I visit them, they might make me return home sooner. And it's not like I miss them or anything."

"Then let's return back to my apartment for now." Yuan nodded.

They returned to the car shortly after and began making their way back to the Cultivators' Association.

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Chapter 645: Moving Out of the Apartment

“So yeah, we need 3.5 billion dollars for our faction’s headquarters.” Wang Ming called his parents to let them know of the situation.

“3.5 billion? Are you buying a house on the moon or something? Why the heck is it so expensive?!”

“No, it’s a house in the Dragon Spiral Mountain.”

“What! The Dragon Spiral Mountain?!”

“Hm? You know of it?”

“Of course! It’s one of the most suitable places in this world for cultivators! If it were not for our family size that consists of six different families, we would’ve moved there!”

“I see... Anyways, I will give you Yuan’s bank information. You can send it to him whenever you’re ready.”

“You sound very confident that we’ll give you the money...” Wang Ming’s father said.

“You’re not? I will let Yuan know right now if that’s the case.”

“W-Wait... I was only joking. Let me speak with the others first, but I’m sure we’ll be able to help him. Even if he needs twice that amount, we’ll be willing to help our savior!” His father said.

After what happened at the Jaded Garden, the people there now address Yuan as their 'Savior'.

Wang Ming hung up the phone shortly after and said to Yuan, "Our families should be sending the money to you as soon as possible."

"Thank you..." He nodded.

Sometime later, they returned to the Cultivators' Association.

"Please follow me to fill out the documents." Chairman Lee said to Yuan.

Yuan followed him to his room, where he had to fill out a whole stack of documents.

"Here are the rules and regulations that you must follow when living inside the Dragon Spiral Mountain. If you break any of these rules, you could be removed from the place. If that happens, even I cannot help you." Chairman Lee handed him a small stack of papers

"Please read all of them and make sure you're okay with them."

Yuan proceeded to spend many minutes carefully reading through the rules.

In short, they are not allowed to destroy the land there, nor are they allowed to bother their neighbors.

If they want to renovate their own property, they'll need approval from the lord of the mountain.

Most of the rules are quite simple, so Yuan didn't spend too much time on them.

Once he finished reading the rules, Yuan signed the paper stating that he understood and is willing to follow the rules.

After all of the documents were signed, Chairman Lee said, "I will handle everything else from here. You can begin your moving as soon as possible."

“What about the payment?” Yuan asked.

“Once you move into the mountain, you’ll be approached by the manager, who will ask for the payment then. You can pay monthly installments or all at once. It’s all up to you.”

“I understand. Thank you for helping us.” Yuan said to him afterward.

“It was a pleasure to help you and your faction, Daoist Yuan. If you ever need anything, you know where to find me.”

After shaking hands, Yuan left the Cultivators’ Association with the others.

“When are you going to move into our new home?” Wang Ming asked him as they walked home.

“As soon as possible,” he said.

“We’ll also be doing the same since we don’t want to live in hotels any longer.”

And before they separated, Yuan handed them some papers.

“Read this when you have the time. They are rules we must follow when living inside the mountain. If we break any of them, we could be removed.”

“Alright.”

Once they returned home, Chu Liuxiang said to Sebastian, who had stayed behind to watch the place, “Guess what, Sebastian.”

“I have no clue.” He shook his head with a smile.

“We’re returning to the Dragon Spiral Mountain,” she said.

“What? Why do you suddenly want to go home?” Sebastian expressed surprise.

“Who said anything about going home? Our new home is also in the Dragon Spiral Mountain, and we’re moving there now.”

“Really?” Sebastian looked at Yuan with a surprised look on his face.

He knew very well how difficult it is to be allowed inside the Dragon Spiral Mountain. Although Yuan is a very talented individual with some fame because of Cultivation Online, that much wouldn’t be nearly enough to let him live inside the mountain, so there must be another reason why they were allowed to live there.

However, he cannot imagine why the lord of the mountain would allow them to move there.

‘Maybe the Chu Family had something to do with it? No... That’s not possible... The masters wouldn’t do something like this...’ Sebastian pondered.

“Why are you standing there, Sebastian? Let’s help them pack so that we can leave this place as soon as possible.”

“My apologies, Young Lady.”

Of course, it didn’t take long for them to pack everything since neither Yuan nor Meixiu had much luggage. Other than their clothes, some miscellaneous things, and Yuan’s piano, there really wasn’t anything else that needed to be moved.

“Oh, right. We should let Xia Jingyi know that we’re moving out of the apartment.” Yuan suddenly remembered.

“I have already texted Yu Rou. She’ll let Xia Jingyi know once they finish training.”

“Perfect. Now we just need to move everything here to our new home.”

Sebastian then said, “We can fit the small luggage inside the car, but the piano will require a larger car.”

“Miss Meixiu, do you know how to drive a limousine? You can drive the limousine while I rent out a truck to take care of the piano.” Sebastian said to her next.

“I can do that.” Meixiu nodded.

“It’s getting dark, so let’s do it tomorrow morning,” Yuan said.

“I understand.”

After eating dinner, everyone went to sleep early.

As for Yuan, he went into Cultivation Online to temper his body again with Lan Yingying.

The following morning, they loaded the small luggage into the limousine while Meixiu effortlessly carried the piano into the truck rented by Sebastian, shocking the pedestrians with her absurd strength.

Once they were ready to move, they began making their way to the Dragon Spiral Mountain.

Chapter 646: Manager of the Dragon Spiral Mountain

A few hours after leaving their apartment, Yuan and the others arrived at the gates of the Dragon Spiral Mountain, and to their surprise, Wang Ming and the others were all waiting outside with their luggage.

“Why are you all waiting out here?” Yuan asked them.

“We couldn’t get inside because we don’t have any identification even though we were here yesterday...” Wang Ming sighed.

“Oh, right... Chairman Lee only gave me one identification for now... I really hope you guys didn’t stay here overnight.”

“No, we only got here about an hour ago, so it wasn’t that bad.”

Yuan nodded, and he went to the guards to show them his identification.

“Welcome to the Dragon Spiral Mountain, Young Master Yuan.” The guards greeted him.

“Where can I get identifications for my companions so they can enter the place without me?” Yuan asked them.

“The Manager will handle all of that once she visits you later today,” said the guards.

“I understand.”

Once the gates were opened, Yuan and the others made their way to their new home in the middle of the mountain.

“Yuan, you can go ahead and pick your room first. We’ll decide afterward.” Wang Ming said to him.

“Well, they’re all pretty much the same, so it doesn’t really matter to me.”

“How about this one? It’s the largest room in this building, and it’s also the closest to the staircase.” Shi Lang suggested.

“Sure.”

“What about you two?” Yuan asked Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang.

“I will live in the room next to yours,” Meixiu said.

“Can I live in the same room as you, Brother Yuan?” Chu Liuxiang asked.

“I don’t really mind, but are you sure? Don’t you want your own room?”

“I already have my own room at the Chu Family’s living quarters. I want to spend as much time as I can with you while I am here,” she said.

“If that’s what you want.” Yuan nodded. He really didn’t mind sharing the room with Chu Liuxiang, as there was more than enough space for two—even three people.

Once Yuan picked his room, the others also went to find their own rooms.

Sometime later, after everyone unpacked their luggage, Li Jinxi approached Yuan with her training sword in her grasp.

“Yuan, let’s spar.”

“Right now...?”

“Yes.” She nodded with a serious face.

She has been waiting for this opportunity ever since she left the Jaded Garden, and not being able to train at her previous hotel only made her desire to train stronger.

“I’m expecting the Manager of the mountain to visit us today, so let’s do it tomorrow.”

“Promise?”

“I promise.”

“Okay.” Li Jinxi then walked away and went to look for someone else to spar with.

Yuan returned to his room and sat on the large bed.

“I’m not used to living in such a large room.” He sighed out loud.

Chu Liuxiang, who was organizing her clothes, said, “Aren’t you glad I’m living in here with you then? It’ll feel less spacious, after all.”

Yuan nodded with a slight smile on his face.

He then asked, “Are you sure you don’t want to visit your family? You should at least let them know that you’re back.”

“It’s fine. Sebastian is already there right now. He’ll let them know,” she said.

“Sebastian? I’ve been wondering why he suddenly disappeared after unloading our luggage.”

“Brother Yuan... You should prepare yourself.” Chu Liuxiang suddenly said.

“Huh? Prepare myself for what?” Yuan raised his eyebrow.

“My family will definitely approach you in the near future, especially now that you’re living in the Dragon Spiral Mountain. I just want you to prepare yourself because they can be a little overbearing at times.”

“I-I will keep that in mind.” Yuan nodded.

Sometime later, Meixiu knocked on his door and said, “Yuan! Someone calling herself ‘Manager’ is here to see you!”

“Thank you! I’m coming!”

Yuan left his room shortly after and followed Meixiu outside, where a beautiful young woman in a business suit was waiting. She had long red hair that was tied into a ponytail, and she held a serious expression on her face that almost looked natural.

“Are you Yuan?” She asked him when he arrived.

“Yes, I am.”

“Hmmm...”

The Manager then took a moment to stare at Yuan’s face, as he wasn’t wearing his mask at this moment.

After a moment of silence, she spoke, “I’m the Manager of the Dragon Spiral Mountain, and I’m here to collect your payment. This is my identification. Will you be doing monthly installments or full payment? If you’re doing monthly installments, we’ll need 500 million as a downpayment.”

“I will do the full payment,” Yuan said.

“Alright. Let’s sit down before we proceed.”

Yuan then led her to the living room.

Once they were seated, the Manager retrieved a laptop and prepared the payment process.

“Please read these documents and sign them while I set up the payment,” she said to him.

A few minutes later, Yuan signed the documents after reading them with Meixiu.

“Here’s the bank information. Please send the money here.” The Manager then showed them the information on her laptop.

Meixiu then used her phone to transfer the money.

A few minutes later, once she confirmed the payment, the Manager said to them, “Congratulations. You’re now officially part of the Dragon Spiral Mountain. You don’t have to pay for the yearly property tax until you have lived here for a whole year. Do you have any questions?”

“How do I get identifications for my friends living here with me?”

“How many people are currently living here with you?”

“Nine people so far.”

The Manager then retrieved 9 badges from her laptop carrying pack and placed them on the table.

“They will be able to enter the mountain as long as they have these badges. Please don’t lose them, or you’ll have to pay a hefty fine of 1 billion dollars for each one you lose. And if you’re caught selling them, you’ll be removed from the mountain.”

“I understand. Thank you.” Yuan said as he accepted the badges.

“Any more questions for me before I leave?”

Chapter 647: Meixiu's New Role

"I actually do have one. What kind of person is the lord of the Dragon Spiral Mountain?" Yuan asked her.

"The lord, huh? Why do you want to know about him?" The Manager held a mysterious smile on her face.

"Out of curiosity, I guess," Yuan said.

"Unfortunately, I cannot tell you anything about the lord. However, if you live here for long enough, you might get to see him."

"Is that so?"

"Anyways, if you have questions about the mountain, you can contact me at any time of the day. Here's my business card." The Manager handed her card to them.

"Jenny Zhang..." Yuan read the name on the business card.

"You can just call me Jenny."

After shaking hands with each other, Manager Jenny left the scene.

"Since this finished earlier than expected, I'll go spar with Li Jinxgi now," Yuan said as he stood up.

"What are you going to do now?"

"I'm not sure, honestly... In fact, I'm wondering what my role— my purpose is now. Am I still your caretaker? It really doesn't feel like it since I have been spending most of my time cultivating..." Meixiu asked him.

Yuan pondered for a moment before speaking, “We’re no longer in a small home with just the two of us. There’s Lulu and the others, not to mention the faction. Furthermore, I will be spending most of my time in Cultivation Online now, so I won’t need any attention. Instead of remaining as my caretaker, why don’t you do something different? Like being the manager of the faction?”

“So basically what my mother is doing?” Meixiu asked.

Even though Meifeng is still the Yu Family’s caretaker, she doesn’t actually do any caretaking at all, leaving all of the chores for the other servants under her. Instead, she manages the Yu Family’s company, such as doing their finances and scheduling their appointments, which has nothing to do with being a caretaker— at least not a normal one.

“If you put it that way, I guess so. After all, you’re Miss Meifeng’s daughter, and I trust you the most when it comes to these kinds of things. You’re smart, responsible, and hardworking. I cannot think of anyone else more fitting than you to manage my— our faction.” Yuan said with a smile.

“...”

Meixiu was left speechless by Yuan’s trust in her, even blushing a bit from his compliments.

“Okay. I will see what I can do.” Meixiu nodded with a resolute face.

Then she realized something.

“What about the actual chores? Who will do them now?” Meixiu asked a moment later.

“That’s a good question...” Yuan pondered for a bit before speaking, “Maybe we should do it ourselves.”

“I would hire people to do the chores, but we’re kind of short on money after moving to this place, and it’ll be a good way to discipline ourselves.”

“Discipline...?” Meixiu raised her eyebrows.

She cannot imagine Wang Ming and the others doing chores, as they're all from powerful and wealthy families, so they're probably used to having other people handling their chores.

"Let's gather everyone first," Yuan said.

Sometime later, everyone gathered in the main lobby.

"What's the matter? Why did you gather everyone, Yuan?" Wang Ming asked him, as they were in the middle of training when they were called.

"Well, I've been talking to Meixiu about our future and how we should take care of this place. I have decided to make Meixiu the manager of the faction, so she will no longer have time to be my caretaker. This means we have nobody to do the chores such as cleaning and cooking, and I'm wondering what we should do."

"Why don't we just hire some people to do it instead? That's what most big families do." Shi Lang suggested.

"I also thought about that, but we're short on money right now, and I don't know how we'll get permission to let these people inside the Dragon Spiral Mountain."

Chu Liuxiang then raised her hand and said, "Actually, the Dragon Spiral Mountain provides free servants if you need people to do chores."

"Huh? Really?"

She nodded and continued, "On the first of every month, the Dragon Spiral Mountain will provide free cleaning services to everyone living in the mountain. However, the downside is that they'll only be available on the first of every month, meaning they won't be there whenever you need something to be cleaned. But unless we're making a mess, we don't need to clean that often."

"If someone makes a mess, they should just clean up after themselves."

Yuan nodded, "That will work. Is everybody okay with this?"

Everyone there nodded.

“What about food? Does this place offer chefs?” Li Jinxi asked.

Chu Liuxiang shook her head and said, “No, we’ll have to either hire them or cook for ourselves.”

Meixiu then said, “If it’s just cooking breakfast and dinner, I can handle that by myself.”

“Are you sure? Won’t you be busy with the faction?” Yuan asked her.

“Even if you tell me to manage the faction, I don’t think there is that much for me to do, especially since we’re new, and we only have 10 people in the faction.”

“If you say so.” Yuan nodded, and he continued, “But if you don’t have time to cook in the future, let me know so we can do something about it.”

“Okay.”

Once everything was settled, Yuan went to spar with Li Jinxi and the others in their backyard, which was just an empty field at the moment.

As for Meixiu, she went to research more about factions and what managers should be doing for their factions.

“Hey, Jinxi, don’t use too much strength when you spar with Yuan. If you damage the land too much...” Wang Ming warned her.

“I know...” she said.

While Yuan sparred with the others, somewhere in the upper level of the Dragon Spiral Mountain, Sebastian greeted Chu Liuxiang’s foster parents.

“I have returned, Master Chu, Madam Chu.” Sebastian bowed to them.

“Sebastian? Why did you suddenly return alone? Where’s my daughter?” Chu Liuxiang’s father asked him.

“The Young Lady is still with Yuan. They are also currently in the Dragon Spiral Mountain, so I decided to return alone and let the Masters know of the situation.”

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Chapter 648: Obsessed

“What? Yuan? What is he doing in the mountain? Even if Chu Liuxiang is with him, he shouldn’t be able to enter the mountain without the lord’s permission.” Chu Shijian, Chu Liuxiang’s foster father, said in a surprised voice.

“He actually moved into the mountain, and he’s currently living in the middle level of the Dragon Spiral Mountain,” Sebastian explained to him.

“He moved into the mountain?! How is that even possible? Although I have no doubt that he’ll be able to live here in the future, he shouldn’t have the qualifications to enter this place yet!”

“I was also surprised when I heard it, but the lord approved it, and he moved in just today.”

“Hmmm...”

Chu Shijian closed his eyes to ponder.

“What do you think of him? This Yuan.” The woman sitting beside Chu Shijian suddenly asked.

“He’s a very talented individual. Perhaps even more talented than our top geniuses. Although I haven’t spent much time with him or seen his full potential, I believe he’s someone worthy of our attention.” Sebastian said.

“I haven’t seen you praise someone like this before, Sebastian. He must have really impressed you.” The woman smiled.

He nodded and said, “While I didn’t witness it for myself, it is true that he’d defeated the demon that was supposedly as strong as a cultivator at the peak

Spirit Grandmaster. I have also watched him practice with the Six Spiritual Families' geniuses. He's the real deal."

"If you never fought one yourself, how do you know that demons are really that powerful? If you ask me, I think they exaggerated the demon's power."

"Exaggerated, huh? I really can't tell you since I wasn't there to witness it..." Sebastian shook his head.

Chu Shijian then spoke, "What about Chu Liuxiang? How would you describe their relationship?"

After a moment of silence, Sebastian spoke, "From what I have witnessed, the Young Lady truly cares about Yuan. In fact, I would even say she's obsessed with him."

"Obsessed?" Madam Chu frowned slightly when she heard this, and she said, "I don't like the sound of this word, especially when it's about one of our members. Although Liuxiang is not blood-related, she still has our surname, so she has the obligation to behave like one."

"Unfortunately, I don't know how else to describe her feelings for him besides 'obsessed. If he asks her to die for him, she most likely wouldn't refuse."

"It's that serious?" The parents looked at each other with perplexed emotions in their eyes. They knew Chu Liuxiang valued Yuan, but they didn't anticipate her feelings would be this intense.

"From what I am hearing... This Yuan doesn't appear to be a good influence on Liuxiang. I think we should separate them as soon as possible before it's too late." Madam Chu suddenly suggested.

Hearing this, Sebastian quickly said, "With all due respect, I don't think that would be a wise decision, Madam Chu."

"Oh? Why not?" She stared at him with narrowed eyes.

“Although Yuan may not have many achievements now, his potential is enormous and we cannot ignore that. If we separate them and offend him... I fear he might retaliate against us in the future.”

“Retaliate... Against us? The Chu Family?” Madam Chu chuckled in a manner that looked down on Sebastian’s claims.

After all, the Chu Family is one of the largest and most influential families in this world. How can a single person possibly affect them, much less threaten them?

“Whether he is worthy or not... I will be the judge of that. Sebastian, continue observing Yuan and my daughter.” Chu Shijian commanded.

“As you wish.”

After speaking with the Chu Family, Sebastian returned to Yuan’s faction.

‘Thank the lord I didn’t mention the Young Lady’s desire to bear Yuan’s child, or the masters would’ve acted immediately... I have done everything I could to support you. It’s all up to you two now...’ Sebastian sighed inwardly.

The following morning, Yuan woke up before sunrise and went to his closet, where he had two zithers stored.

He retrieved the plain-looking zither and went outside with it.

After taking a seat in the middle of the field, he began playing the zither.

A few songs later, Yuan took a deep breath and sighed in a low voice, “I will be fighting the Sect Master of the Blood Sect today... And I might have to kill him in order to protect the others... But I hope things don’t go that far...”

Once he cleared his mind, Yuan returned to his room and wore the console on his head, entering Cultivation Online.

“Young Master, where are you going?” Feng Yuxiang and the others asked him when he noticed him trying to leave the Luo Family by himself.

“I’m going to fight the Blood Sect,” he calmly responded.

“Then we’re coming—”

“No.” Yuan quickly interrupted.

And he continued, “You stay here— all of you. I can handle them by myself.”

“Young Master, while we don’t doubt that you can deal with the Blood Sect by yourself, I think we should still be there just in case anything happens.” Feng Yuxiang said.

“Please, let me fight them alone,” Yuan said to them in a slightly nervous tone.

“I don’t want any of you to see me covered in blood.”

“Are you worried that we might see you differently because you killed a few people?” Feng Yuxiang suddenly asked him.

Yuan silently nodded.

“Don’t worry, Young Master. We won’t see you in a different light just because you killed a few trash. This is the cultivation world, after all. Cultivators killing other Cultivators is as natural as breathing in this world, and you’re doing it for a good cause. In fact, you’ll even be seen as a hero for your actions.”

Yuan then sighed, “While what you say might be true, I won’t be able to concentrate with you guys there. Furthermore, I want you to stay here just in case the Blood Sect attacks this city when I am gone.”

“Young Master—”

“Good luck and stay safe, Brother Yuan.” Xiao Hua suddenly interrupted.

“Thank you.”

Yuan left the place shortly after.

“Why did you let him go alone? What if something happens to him?” Feng Yuxiang asked Xiao Hua afterward.

“This is Brother Yuan’s decision. We can only believe in him,” she calmly responded.

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Chapter 649: Fighting the Blood Sect

“Where is Daoist Yuan?” Lord Luo asked Xiao Hua and the others after he left, unaware of the situation.

“The Young Master left not long ago to deal with the Blood Sect,” said Feng Yuxiang.

“Eh?” Lord Luo looked at the three of them. If they’re all here, this meant that Yuan had gone to deal with the Blood Sect by himself.

Seeing Lord Luo’s expression, Lan Yingying said, “Yuan will be fine. Don’t underestimate him.”

“I-I understand...”

Meanwhile, at the Flying Sword Sect, Yuan stood before the three stone tablets with a tranquil expression on his face.

However, inside his mind, he was trying to communicate with somebody.

‘Are you going to show up today and take control of my body like last time? You like killing people, right?’

He would rather let the handsome man take control of his body so that he doesn’t have to personally kill the Blood Sect, and he would feel less guilt that way.

Unfortunately, the handsome man would not respond no matter how much Yuan tried to summon him.

Yuan sighed.

And for the next two hours, he would patiently wait for the Blood Sect to show up at the three stone tablets.

“Hm?”

Yuan snapped out of his daze when he could suddenly sense many presences appearing around him, and these presences would reek of bloodlust.

Furthermore, these presences would continue to appear without stopping for many minutes.

Tens, hundreds, thousands— Yuan was suddenly surrounded in all directions by thousands of Cultivators ranging from Spirit Apprentice to Spirit Master, and there was even a single Spirit Grandmaster amongst them.

“They brought the whole sect here even though I only called for their Sect Master...?” A bittersweet smile appeared on Yuan’s face, as he was only hoping to fight their Sect Master and a few other people, not their entire sect.

Eventually, Yuan no longer needed to sense them, as he could see these people with his eyes, and as expected, it was as though he was being surrounded by a black sea made out of people.

However, Yuan tried to remain calm and waited for their Sect Master to appear.

A few minutes later, once the people there stopped moving, Yuan could see a figure hovering in the sky, and this person was slowly approaching him.

This person had long white hair that reached his feet, a short white beard, and two bloodshot eyes that made it seem as though he hasn’t slept for weeks.

“Are you the bastard that killed my son?” The Blood Sect’s Sect Master, Lord Blood, asked once he stopped moving a few meters in front of Yuan.

Yuan closed his eyes and took a deep breath before speaking in a clear voice, “That’s right.”

“Why did you kill him?” Lord Blood continued to ask.

Yuan opened his eyes, revealing the coldness within, and he responded, “Because he was an eyesore.”

Lord Blood visibly trembled when he heard Yuan’s words, but he managed to barely control his emotions.

“Are you mad? Even though you guys from the Blood Sect had killed so many innocent people? Have you heard of ‘Karma’?” Yuan looked at Lord Blood straight into his red eyes, ignoring everyone else.

After a moment of silence, Lord Blood spoke, “I don’t believe you.”

“You don’t believe me...?” Yuan raised his eyebrows.

“You can bullsh*t all you want, but I can tell whether someone is a killer or not just by looking at bloodlust in their aura, and I have a strong sense of smell for blood. Forget bloodlust, you smell like you have never touched blood before. There’s no way someone like you killed my son.” Lord Blood coldly sneered.

Yuan didn’t say anything else and retrieved the Empyrean Overlord, and that immediately alerted everyone there, causing them to draw their weapons and enter a defensive position.

However, Yuan didn’t attack anyone and merely used the technique Bloody Sword Strike in front of everyone there.

Lord Blood’s face immediately paled after seeing this technique.

“Y-Y-You...”

He was at a loss for words, as only core disciples and above from their Blood Sect could learn the Bloody Sword Strike.

“Where did you obtain that technique?” Lord Blood asked him in a grim voice.

“Where do you think I obtained it?” Yuan responded with a mocking smile on his face.

“YOU BASTARD!” Lord Blood could no longer control his emotions and roared.

“GET HIM! I WANT HIM ALIVE SO THAT I CAN TORTURE HIM LATER!” He commanded the thousands of disciples there.

Upon hearing their Sect Master’s command, the Blood Sect disciples did not hesitate to challenge a Spirit Grandmaster and rushed at Yuan.

Seeing this, Yuan took a deep breath and mumbled to himself, “It’s okay. The world is better off without them. They will kill countless innocent people if I don’t stop them today. They may have the appearance of a human, but their hearts are no different than a demon— cruel, bloodthirsty, and inhumane.”

“In order to protect Pang City... The Luo Family... and everyone else... I must stop them here...”

“They’re just ants... beasts... demons...”

After taking a moment to convince himself to act, Yuan tightened his grasp on the Emyrean Overlord before swinging it like a madman.

“HAAAAAA!”

Yuan used Bloody Sword Strike, sending a massive red arc of sword light at the Blood Sect disciples that were charging at him.

Whoosh!

The arc of sword light swept the crowd and shredded their bodies in halves instantly and effortlessly.

With a single strike, Yuan had killed dozens of people from the Blood Sect, but the others didn't even bat an eyelid and continued to run at him like a bunch of mindless beasts.

Seeing their unnatural reaction, Yuan felt relieved, as this made them seem less human and more like beasts in his eyes.

Very quickly, rivers of blood were created and washed over the dried blood in the Flying Sword Sect, and corpses piled up like mountains.

Although Yuan was too occupied to realize it, the scenery there was quickly becoming the bloody dream he had a while ago, and somewhere deep within his consciousness, a familiar voice praised his actions as he continued to slaughter the Blood Sect.

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Chapter 650: Destroying the Blood Sect

Whoosh!

“Ahhhh!”

Bang!

“Aaaaaggghhh!”

Blood and body parts scattered all over the place as Yuan continued to swing the Empyrean Overlord without mercy.

Tens— hundreds of disciples from the Blood Sect were slaughtered at the hands of Yuans, yet their Sect Master, Lord Blood, remained hovering in the sky without moving a single finger, silently watching his disciples getting slaughtered in the bulk with a cold gaze.

Of course, he never really expected the disciples that were mostly Spirit Apprentices and Spirit Warriors to capture Yuan, who was a Spirit Grandmaster.

Even if he had tens of thousands of disciples, it would not be enough for a Spirit Grandmaster.

His only motive was to tire out Yuan with his disciples so that he would have a better time taking him down later. In other words, he was sacrificing his own disciples for himself.

As for the disciples, they had no choice but to fight Yuan, even if they might die. After all, if they don't listen to Lord Blood, they will definitely

die at the hands of their own Sect Master.

“Get him! He won’t be able to defeat all of us!”

“For Lord Blood!”

The disciples continued to rush at Yuan despite his overwhelming presence.

“Heavenly Domain!”

A profound aura suddenly appeared around Yuan, instantly pressuring before flattening the disciples there into meat paste.

Blood splattered all over Yuan’s body and face, but when the blood touched his Golden Dragon Robes, they would slide right off, almost as though it was coated in a thick layer of liquid-resistance substance.

However, the blood on his face remained, and some of it even got into his eyes, making it seem as though he was crying blood.

“Haaaa!”

Yuan swung again, and another dozen people died.

‘Ah... What exactly am I doing...? I can’t feel anything...’ Yuan wondered inwardly he as subconsciously swung the Empyrean Overlord in every direction.

‘There’s something hitting my face... Is it raining?’

‘Why am I doing this again?’

‘You’re doing this to protect the innocent... Just like you always have...’ Another voice suddenly resounded in his head.

‘Who are you?’

‘Me? You should already know the answer to that question.’ The voice responded.

And it continued, ‘The sensation of their flesh tearing apart... The smell of blood... The profound atmosphere... Their blood-curdling screams... Remember it... Remember it all...’

Flashbacks began occurring inside Yuan’s head, but he still managed to fight the Blood Sect.

After an unknown amount of time have passed, Yuan snapped out of his flashbacks, finding himself in the middle of a bloodbath.

All of the Blood Sect disciples beside the Sect Master had been wiped out before he realized.

Yuan lifted his hands to see that both his hands were covered in blood. His clothes were fine without a drop of blood on them for some reason, but his long hair was dripping in blood.

The stench of blood and spilled organs assaulted Yuan’s nose, causing his body to tremble, but it was not fear or shock that he was feeling— it was the feeling of nostalgia.

“What are you going to do now that all of your disciples are dead?” Yuan slowly lifted his head to look at Lord Blood with a profound gaze.

“I am going to kill you now for taking away my son from me, of course.”

Lord Blood descended from the sky with a red sword in his grasp that pulsed as though it had veins hidden within.

He pointed the sword at Yuan as dozens of veins appeared on his head, all looking as though it could pop at any second.

“YOU. WILL. PAY. FOR. KILLING. MY. SON!” He growled in a slow and cold voice.

Yuan momentarily ignored Lord Blood and turned to look at the three stone tablets not far away.

“You will also pay... for killing my friend.”

Yuan tightened his grasp on the Empyrean Overlord.

“DIE FOR ME!”

Lord Blood rushed at Yuan a moment later.

Yuan welcomed his blade with a grim smile.

Clang!

Clang!

Clang!

They fought back and forth for many minutes with neither of them getting a lead on the other.

Of course, Yuan was going easy on Lord Blood, as he could easily kill someone at Lord Blood's level with ease.

‘Why?! Why isn't he tired after fighting thousands of Cultivators?! Does he have unlimited stamina or something?!’ Lord Blood was shocked inwardly when he cannot gain an advantage over Yuan.

‘I am one level above him, and he's fought thousands of Cultivators! Why is he still able to fight me?!’

“Thousands of people died because of you.” Yuan suddenly spoke.

“And no, I am not talking about the ‘people’ around us. They don't deserve to be called people. They're animals— beasts.”

“Shut up! I kill whoever I want to kill! I am the Sect Master of the Blood Sect! Whoever lives or dies is within my discretion!” Lord Blood laughed.

Yuan released a deep sigh after hearing his words.

“You're really just a beast— nothing more...”

Yuan suddenly distanced himself from Lord Blood and stopped moving.

“Do you want to know how your son died?” He asked after a moment of silence.

Lord Blood narrowed his eyes that were filled with hatred.

“This is what killed him.”

Yuan raised his sword into the air for a moment before sending it downwards.

“Heaven Splitting Sword Strike!”

“This is...”

Lord Blood was too shocked to react, allowing the beam of light to consume his body, and almost instantaneously, his body disappeared with the light.

Yuan released a deep and profound sigh of relief after killing Lord Blood.

Suddenly—

Ding!

[Congratulations! You have exterminated the Blood Sect!]

[You have completed a Hidden Quest!]

[Fame +1,000!]

[Congratulations! You have obtained the title ‘Sect Destroyer’!]

Ding!

[Due to your actions that vanquished thousands of evil souls, your reputation within the faction has increased significantly!]

[Your faction rank has ranked up!]

[Faction Rank: Warrior]

Ding!

[Congratulations! Your Soul Weapon Empyrean Overlord has absorbed enough spiritual energy and leveled up!]

[Your Empyrean Overlord's Unique Ability has leveled up!]

[Empyrean Overlord]

[Level: 2]

[Rank: Soul Weapon]

[Growth Rate: Very Slow]

[Unique Ability: (Emperor's Domination) Amplify the power of all sword techniques by 300% when wielding this sword]

After all of the notifications came and went, Yuan looked around the place and pondered for a moment.

Sometime later, he began walking around the place, picking up the spatial rings and pouches that no longer had an owner.

‘I am currently short on money, and I cannot rely on Feng Feng forever...’

Of course, Yuan hoped to sell these spatial rings and the treasures inside for some gold later.

After gathering all of the spatial rings he could find, including Lord Blood's spatial ring, Yuan quietly left the scene and made his way back to Pang City.

“I-It's the Blood Sect!”

When the guards saw Yuan's bloody appearance, they immediately mistook him for someone in the Blood Sect and drew their weapons at him, yet their legs couldn't help but shake uncontrollably.

"Calm down. It's me, Yuan." He said to them.

"T-The Hero? W-Why is your appearance like that? What happened to you?" They asked him in a trembling voice.

"I had some business to settle with the Blood Sect. That's all," he said in a calm voice.

"T-That's all?" The guards exchanged dumbfounded glances with each other.

"I'd like to return to the Luo Family and quickly wash myself if you don't mind."

"R-Right away!" The guards immediately allowed him into the city.

Yuan didn't say anything else and made his way back to the Luo Family, where Xiao Hua and the others were waiting.

"Brother Yuan..."

"Young Master..."

"Yuan..."

His companions were clearly shocked speechless by Yuan's bloody appearance.

"Don't worry, this isn't my blood. I will explain everything later, but right now, I need to use the bathroom."

The three of them could only nod their heads in silence.

After entering the bathroom, Yuan would proceed to spend almost two hours washing the blood off his body and hair.

Once he was done, he sat before the Luo Family and the others in another room.

“D-Daoist Yuan... What happened?” Lord Luo asked him.

Yuan didn’t immediately respond. Instead, he retrieved Lord Blood’s spatial ring and a bloodied medallion, which read ‘Blood Sect Authority’.

“T-That’s something only the Sect Master of the Blood Sect should have! Why do you have that?!” Lord Luo exclaimed in a terrified voice when he saw the medallion.

“I killed him and took it from him,” Yuan responded in a calm voice.

“Y-You killed Lord Blood? But his disciples— the Blood Sect will...”

“The Blood Sect won’t do anything to me... Since I killed most of if not all of their disciples as well.”

“...”

The room turned silent after Yuan finished his sentence, and everyone there could only stare at him with clear disbelief on their faces.

“This is what happened...”

Yuan then explained the situation to them and how he fought against the entire Blood Sect by himself.

Chapter 651: Heart Demon

“Young Master... Don’t blame yourself... You did nothing wrong by killing those evil Cultivators.” Feng Yuxiang spoke a moment after Yuan explained his battle with the Blood Sect, as there was a clear sense of guilt within his eyes as he explained how he killed thousands of disciples from the Blood Sect.

However, Yuan shook his head and sighed in a low voice, “You’re wrong. I am neither feeling guilt nor self-blame because I killed those evil Cultivators. I am worried because I don’t feel any sympathy even after killing so many people...”

“Even now, I cannot feel anything. Is there something wrong with me?”

“That’s completely normal, Young Master. It just means your consciousness doesn’t find anything wrong with killing some evildoers. I can assure you that there’s nothing wrong with you. You’re just growing up— as a Cultivator. That’s it.”

“Growing up, huh?” Yuan sighed.

Sometime later, Yuan said to Lord Luo, “Pang City should be safe now that the Blood Sect is gone.”

“T-Thank you, Daoist Yuan! Once again, you have saved our city!” Lord Luo stood up and bowed to him.

“Unfortunately, our family doesn’t have anything else to give you, as I had already given you our most valuable treasure.”

“The Starry Abyss, huh?” Yuan suddenly retrieved the Starry Abyss.

“I still haven’t thanked you for giving me this treasure. It has been really useful to me ever since then. This treasure is more than enough to compensate for everything I have done for the city... as well as what I will do for it in the future. Of course, I hope nothing bad happens to this place ever again.”

“Thank you, Daoist Yuan.”

After talking with each other for a little more, Yuan returned to his own room.

“I am going to spend some time clearing my mind,” Yuan said to them.

He then turned to look at Feng Yuxiang and said, “Feng Feng, can you do me a favor?”

“Anything for the Young Master!”

“I will be taking Meixiu and another friend with me to climb the Stairway to Heaven, but they’re not here. Can you bring them here for me?”

“Another friend?” Feng Yuxiang raised her eyebrow.

Yuan proceeded to give her Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang’s location.

“I should return in two days,” she said after calculating how long it would take to bring them back.

She then handed him a bunch of treasures and said, “If you want to temper your body while I am gone, you can use this. Ah, here, let me separate it for you.”

After separating the treasures, Feng Yuxiang left Pang City to pick up Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang.

Meanwhile, Yuan went to the courtyard and sat under a tree with his eyes closed, seemingly cultivating.

“Yuan... He’s changed.” Lan Yingying, who was watching him from a distance with Xiao Hua, mumbled in a low voice.

“This change will only benefit Brother Yuan, who intends on climbing the Stairway to Heaven.” Xiao Hua said.

Sometime later, a figure approached Yuan and asked him, “Are you okay?”

Yuan opened his eyes and turned around to see Min Li standing behind him with a slightly worried face.

“Have you ever killed people before?” Yuan suddenly asked her.

Min Li shook her head and said, “No, but I have come close to killing someone a few times in my life.”

“I heard you destroyed the Blood Sect by yourself. I didn’t think such a thing was possible, but knowing you... I guess nothing is impossible.”

“Hopefully, I didn’t destroy myself in the process.” Yuan sighed.

“Why would you say something like that?” Min Li looked at him with raised eyebrows.

“I can tell that I am changing. I am feeling emotions I have never felt before, and I am doing things that I could’ve never imagined doing. I’m afraid that it’ll change me completely sooner or later.”

“Is it really that bad? People change. We’re both still young, so we have a lot of room and time to change.”

“Aren’t you afraid that you could become someone you don’t want to become? What if I suddenly become a cold-blooded killer?” Yuan asked.

Min Li chuckled and said, “Trust me, you could be anything, but a cold-blooded killer isn’t one of these things.”

“How can you tell?”

Min Li shrugged, “Who knows. Just a hunch, I guess.”

“Anyways, although some may say that one has no control over what kind of person they may become... I believe the complete opposite— that it’s all in your hands who you want to become.”

Yuan showed a slight smile on his face after her words that sounded oddly familiar, as Xiao Hua had said similar words before.

“Don’t think too much about it, Yuan. You had to do what was necessary. If you let this consume you, it could grow into a real heart demon in the future, and you really don’t want that.” Min Li then said.

“A heart demon? What’s that?”

“It’s something that manifests in your heart— your greatest fears or anything traumatic, really. Once you have a heart demon, it will be incredibly hard to get rid of it, and it will hinder your cultivation until you get rid of it, which requires you to face your fear or trauma.”

“Is it common for someone to have a heart demon?” Yuan asked.

“Of course. In fact, it’s really common. Although most people are not aware that they have a heart demon since it lingers within the deepest parts of their consciousness, I wouldn’t be surprised if out of 10 Cultivators, 8 or 9 of them have some sort of heart demon lying dormant within their consciousness.”

“In my case, even though I have already left them behind, my family will probably become my heart demon in the future.” Min Li sighed with a bittersweet smile.

“I see... Thank you, Disciple Min. You’ve helped me calm down a lot.”

“Just call me Min Li— or even Min.”

“I understand, Min.”

Sometime later, Yuan stood up and said to her, “Anyways, you should get ready if you aren’t already. We’ll be challenging the Stairway to Heaven in a few days.”

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Chapter 652: Revealing His True Background

“It’s been a while, Meixiu.” Feng Yuxiang greeted her with a calm smile on her face.

“Hello, Feng Feng. How have you been?”

“The same as usual. What about you? Anything new since our last meeting?”

“A lot has happened since then...” Meixiu sighed.

“Want to talk to me about it while we go pick up the Young Master’s other friend?” Feng Yuxiang asked as she picked up Meixiu with Qi Manifestation.

“Just a little.” Meixiu nodded.

Meanwhile, news of what happened to the Blood Sect spread like wildfire throughout the entire Lower Heavens, and within a single day, nearly everybody has heard about it.

“Have you heard?! Someone named ‘Yuan’ has managed to destroy the Blood Sect!”

“I have heard about it, but is it even possible to completely destroy an evil sect? Even if you killed a few hundred disciples from the Blood Sect, they won’t be destroyed unless you exterminate all of their disciples. They’re like cockroaches.”

“That’s the thing. He didn’t just kill a few hundred disciples— he killed thousands of them! Of course, this includes their Sect Master and all of the high-ranking disciples that Lord Blood brought with him. It’ll be hard for them to rebuild after this even if they’re the Blood Sect.”

“And they still lost to a single man? Heavens, how powerful is this Yuan person? And how come I haven’t heard of him until today?”

“I believe there was also a disciple with the same name in the Dragon Essence Temple.”

“Oh! I heard about him! He’s the one who carried their sect to first place in the Mystic Realm, right?”

The Dragon Essence Temple’s reputation also rose because of Yuan’s achievements.

Eventually, the news reached the ears of the Players, which caused quite a commotion in the real world.

“Rumor has it Player Yuan destroyed an entire sect by himself!”

“How do we know it’s the real Player Yuan and not some phony?”

“Who else but the real Player Yuan can erase an entire sect by himself?!”

“Are you sure that’s not some exaggerated story created by his fans? They do that quite often.”

“No, it’s real this time! NPCs around the world are talking about it, and I even went to the Flying Sword Sect to look at the battlefield! The place was still covered in blood and corpses when I got there! I have never seen anything that brutal and gruesome before! And he did it all by himself!”

“By himself? Just how powerful is Player Yuan now? After being silent for some time, he suddenly appears again and destroys an entire sect? I’m telling you, he’s a damn cheater!”

At the Eternal Lotuses' headquarters, Xia Jingyi shared the news to Yu Rou, who wasn't impressed by it as she would normally be.

In fact, she became worried after learning that Yuan had destroyed an entire sect and killed thousands of people.

"Are you sure it's Brother Yuan? I don't believe it! There's no way that he could kill so many people even if it's just a game!" Yu Rou denied it.

"I know! It must be one of these fake news created by his fandom to boost his reputation! It has been happening more and more frequently!"

"It's true, Sister Rou. It's all over the forums right now." Xia Jingyi sighed.

Yu Rou turned silent for a good moment.

"It must be because of what happened at the Jaded Garden... Meixiu said Brother Yuan had lost a dear friend to the demon. That tragedy must have changed him." Yu Rou sighed.

"Brother Yuan is in pain, yet I am not there for him..."

After pondering for a bit, Yu Rou looked at Xia Jingyi and said in a resolute voice, "I am going to meet with Brother Yuan in Cultivation Online tomorrow."

She then called Meixiu.

However, nobody picked up since Meixiu was busy in Cultivation Online, so she sent a text message instead.

The following morning, Meixiu returned Yu Rou's call.

"Sorry, Yu Rou. I was inside Cultivation Online the whole night yesterday, so I couldn't answer your call. Did you need something?" Meixiu asked.

"Can you tell my brother that I want to meet him in Cultivation Online tonight if it's possible?"

“Of course. I will let him know. Oh, where are you located right now? I will ask Feng Feng to pick you up.”

After giving Meixiu the location and time, Yu Rou closed the call and went to morning practice.

Meanwhile, Meixiu told Yuan about Yu Rou’s meeting request during breakfast.

“Brother Yuan’s little sister, huh? I have been wanting to meet her for a while now.” Chu Liuxiang mumbled with a profound smile after hearing the news.

“Yuan, you have a little sister? Since when?” Wang Ming and the others were also intrigued, as this was their first time hearing about it.

“Since I was adopted into the Yu Family,” he said with a smile, not even bothering to hide it.

“Huh? Yu Family?” They looked at each other, wondering why it sounded so familiar.

“My other name is Yu Tian, and I used to be in the Yu Family—the one that owns a music and entertainment company in this city.” Yuan suddenly revealed his real identity to them.

Not only did he trust these people, but he also no longer had any reasons to hide his identity.

“Wait? That Yu Family? Heavens... I would have never imagined that you had such an... ordinary background... I thought you came from an Immortal family or something similar!” Wang Ming exclaimed.

The people there were shocked. Although the Yu Family is quite influential and big, they were nothing in the eyes of the Six Spiritual Family.

“Why did you use past tense when speaking about the Yu Family? Are you no longer with them?” Li Jinxi noticed this detail and asked him.

“That’s right. I am not part of that family anymore. They kicked me out, after all.”

“WHAT?!”

Li Jinxi and the others were even more shocked to hear this piece of information. Why on earth would the Yu Family abandon such a heaven-defying genius that makes even their Six Spiritual Family jealous?

“Are they insane?” Wang Ming blurted out his thoughts that were shared by everyone there.

Yuan smiled and said, “Let me tell you a little bit about my background.”

Thus, Yuan would go on and tell them about his history with the Yu Family and how they abandoned him when he became crippled, leaving them speechless.

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Chapter 653: Picking Up Chu Liuxiang

“Hahahaha! I-I’m sorry for laughing, but I really cannot help it after listening to your story! How stupid can the Yu Family be?!” Wang Ming laughed out loud.

“Abandoning their own son because he became a cripple? It’s so ridiculous it’s funny!”

“The fact that they abandoned the one and only Player Yuan without even being aware of it!”

“Ahem!” Li Jinxi suddenly cleared her throat, causing Wang Ming to stop laughing.

She then turned to look at Yuan with a serious face, “Yuan, do you want to get revenge on the Yu Family? Our families can destroy them with ease, after all.”

“Revenge? It’s fine.”

“Why? Don’t you feel angry? Any normal person would detest their family if they were abandoned.”

“I never said I wasn’t angry at them. In fact, my anger grows every time I am reminded of them,” he spoke in a calm voice.

“Then why don’t you want revenge?”

“I want revenge, but I want to do it my own way— by myself.”

“I understand. That’s even better.” Li Jinxi nodded with a smile.

After breakfast, Yuan returned to his own room with Chu Liuxiang.

“I thought you didn’t want revenge against your family for abandoning you, Brother Yuan.” Chu Liuxiang said with a cheeky smile on her face.

“Well... Things change...” Yuan smiled back.

“Anyways, have you met Feng Feng yet?” He asked a moment later.

“No, not yet, but I should meet her soon, and my anticipation is very high.”

“High? Why?”

“Who knows.” Chu Liuxiang shrugged before lying on the bed and putting on the console.

As for Yuan, he went to play the zither for some time before going to the field to spar with the others since he had nothing else to do in Cultivation Online until Feng Yuxiang brings Meixiu and the others to the city.

Meanwhile, Chu Liuxiang was casually standing underneath a tree outside this small city somewhere in the Northern Continent, silently staring at the sky.

“Hello, beautiful young lady. I cannot help but notice you standing there in a daze from the corner of my eyes, as you were just so dazzling—”

“You can leave me alone.” Chu Liuxiang turned to look at the handsome young man standing in front of her.

“Don’t be like that. There seems to be a lot in your mind. If you want, I’d be happy to hear you—”

“I am thinking about the love of my life, so I would like it for you to leave me alone,” she interrupted again.

“T-That... I...”

The young man became speechless after hearing her words.

However, Chu Liuxiang was simply too beautiful for him to give her up so easily. It was a once-in-a-lifetime chance for him.

Unfortunately, before he could open his mouth again, he noticed another figure at the corner of his eyes, and this figure had descended from the sky, causing him to turn his focus.

“Are you the Young Master’s friend?” Feng Yuxiang asked her.

“Young Master?” Chu Liuxiang raised her eyebrows.

“That’s her, Feng Feng,” Meixiu said in a calm voice.

The young man was stunned by the sudden appearance of Feng Yuxiang and Meixiu. He has never seen so many top beauties at once before.

“Well then, what are we waiting for?”

And before the Young Man or Chu Liuxiang could even react, Feng Yuxiang lifted Chu Liuxiang into the air before flying away.

“Y-You’re certainly in a rush, Feng Feng...” Meixiu said to her as they soared in the sky.

“I promised the Young Master that I’d return to his side in two days, and I didn’t add into account that I’d have to pick up Yu Rou as well! Even if she wasn’t part of the plan, I intend on keeping my promise!”

“Are you okay, Chu Liuxiang?” Meixiu turned to look at her, who had a bewildered expression on her face.

“W-We’re flying?!” She exclaimed in a shocked voice.

“First time?” Feng Yuxiang smiled.

“Obviously! You could’ve at least warned me before lifting me into the air! My heart skipped a beat back there!” Chu Liuxiang cried out loud.

Once Chu Liuxiang calmed down and was more comfortable being in the sky, Feng Yuxiang introduced herself, “My name is Feng Yuxiang, but my friends call me Feng Feng. I am the Young Master’s most loyal servant. Nice to meet you.”

“I am called Chu Liuxiang.”

“That’s all? Tell me more about your relationship with the Young Master! How did you meet each other?” Feng Yuxiang then asked.

“I am his childhood friend. We met in an orphanage.” Chu Liuxiang said.

“W-Wait...”

Feng Yuxiang suddenly stopped moving and looked at Chu Liuxiang with wide eyes.

“T-The Young Master... He’s an orphan?”

Although she had many theories on Yuan’s mysterious background, being an orphan was definitely not one of them.

“He never told you?” Chu Liuxiang nodded her head.

Feng Yuxiang quickly shook hers.

“I understand why the Young Master never speaks of his family now... It’s because he never really had one...” Feng Yuxiang sighed upon this realization.

Sometime later, they continued their journey to pick up Yu Rou.

“Why are you staring at me?” Chu Liuxiang asked Meixiu when she noticed her gaze.

“You... Your cultivation... I’m speechless...” Meixiu responded in a dazed voice.

“Hm? What about it?” Chu Liuxiang tilted her head in a questioning manner.

“Well... It’s a lot lower than I’d anticipated...”

“What did you expect? I already mentioned that I didn’t spend much time in this world.”

“I know... but... Second Level Spirit Apprentice... Wow...”

Chu Liuxiang, who was a Spirit Master in the real world, turned out to be only at the second level of Spirit Apprentice in Cultivation Online, something most people can achieve within a few hours of creating their character!

“I mean... I never really intended on playing this game seriously, and I am already cultivating in the real world, so there’s no reason why I need to waste my time increasing my cultivation in this world.” Chu Liuxiang shrugged casually.

“That makes sense... I guess...”

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Chapter 654: Confession

A few hours later, Feng Yuxiang stopped moving above a city in the Eastern Continent.

“We have arrived,” she said to the other two girls.

“I see Yu Rou. She’s over there.” Meixiu pointed at the small figure standing outside the city gates.

Of course, she was surrounded by young men, just like when Yuan first found her.

“Young fairy, why are you standing out here alone? Why don’t you come with me and I will show you all around the city and some more?”

“No, you should follow me! My father is the—”

“Eh? Y-You’re floating?!”

The people there were shocked when Yu Rou suddenly started levitating off the ground.

“S-She’s not floating! She’s flying! A Spirit Grandmaster!”

They then watched as Yu Rou flew towards Feng Yuxiang and the others in the sky.

“It’s been a while, Yu Rou. I hope I didn’t interrupt your fun down there.” Feng Yuxiang said to her with a smile.

“You came just at the right time, Feng Feng.”

“Then let’s return to the Young Master’s side, shall we? We’re already behind schedule.”

Feng Yuxiang then carried all three of them back to Pang City.

Shortly after they began their journey, Yu Rou noticed someone there that she didn’t recognize at all— Chu Liuxiang.

“Hello, I am called Yu Rou. Are you also one of Brother Yuan’s friends? I’m his sister— little sister.” Yu Rou asked her.

Chu Liuxiang narrowed her eyes on Yu Rou with a profound smile on her face, “So you’re Yu Rou, huh? How surprising. You’re nothing like I’d anticipated— completely different from your parents. The polar opposite, even.”

“M-My parents?” Yu Rou’s eyes slightly widened.

“You’re from the Yu Family, no?”

“Oh... So you’re also a player... I assumed you were an NPC since Brother Yuan doesn’t really have any acquaintances out there. This makes more sense.” Yu Rou mumbled after realizing this fact.

“Name’s Chu Liuxiang.”

“How did you and my brother meet? What is your relationship with him? And for how long have you known him?” Yu Rou quickly began interrogating her.

“Brother Yuan and I go back... way back. I have known him for many years now. As for our relationship together, we’re friends... For now, at least.” Chu Liuxiang said, still with a smile.

“B-Brother Yuan...?” Yu Rou frowned slightly.

While Xiao Hua also addresses Yuan as ‘brother’, Yu Rou didn’t mind it as much since Xiao Hua was an NPC, and she also has the appearance of a

little kid. Chu Liuxiang, however, is a young lady around Yuan's age, so Yu Rou wasn't as accepting this time.

Yu Rou turned to look at Meixiu for answers.

However, Meixiu acted as though she didn't notice Yu Rou's intensive gaze, leaving her alone to deal with Chu Liuxiang.

'I'm sorry, Yu Rou, but I'll let you experience— handle her...' Meixiu sighed inwardly.

"C-Calling your friend 'brother' is a little bit weird, don't you think?" Yu Rou asked a moment later.

"Weird? Why? Even if it's a little weird, I cannot help it, as I'd gotten used to calling him that ever since we were young."

"Young?" Yu Rou grew even more puzzled after hearing such words.

How could Chu Liuxiang possibly know Yuan when they were young when her family doesn't allow Yuan to associate with the outside world, much less have friends?

"Are you a fan of my brother? From when he was still performing on the stage?" Yu Rou could only come to this conclusion after a quick pondering.

"Hm? No, we go even further back." Chu Liuxiang shook her head.

"Even further back? That's not possible—"

Yu Rou suddenly halted her mouth movements when she realized something.

"D-Don't tell me..."

"That's right! We were at the same orphanage! I have known him before he was taken away from me by your Yu Family!" Chu Liuxiang said with a smile on her face, unaware that Yu Rou wasn't supposed to know this information.

Although Meixiu didn't realize it at first, she realized the problem afterward, but it was already too late, as Chu Liuxiang had already revealed the secret that Yuan was adopted into the Yu Family— that he wasn't really Yu Rou's real brother.

“Hm?” Seeing Meixiu facepalm herself, Chu Liuxiang raised her eyebrows, still unaware that she had accidentally revealed a secret that Meixiu and Yuan had been hiding for many years now.

Even with her Chu Family's intelligence agency, there was no way that they could've known that Yu Rou didn't know Yuan was adopted.

Seeing Yu Rou's blank face, Meixiu opened her mouth to try and salvage the impossible situation.

“Y-Yu Rou... I can explain...”

“It's fine, Meixiu. You don't have to explain anything to me.” Yu Rou suddenly interrupted.

“Actually, I have a confession to make.”

“I have known about Brother Yuan's adoption— that he is not really my brother for a long time now.”

It was now Yu Rou's turn to reveal this shocking information.

“H-How did you...” Meixiu stared at Yu Rou with a dazed face.

“How did I find out? It was actually by pure coincidence that I found out. I snuck inside my father's room one time when I was playing hide-and-seek with you since I knew you couldn't go there, and I stumbled upon it inside the closet. After learning about it, I began investigating it to confirm the information, and sure enough, it was true.”

“How long have you known about it?” Meixiu then asked.

“Shortly after Brother Yuan became unable to move his body...” Yu Rou sighed.

“For that long?!” Meixiu was truly shocked speechless now.

To think Yu Rou had managed to hide this fact for so many years. It was truly a shock to Meixiu.

“Wait... So you’re telling me that you didn’t always know about Brother Yuan’s adoption?” Chu Liuxiang finally spoke after comprehending the situation.

Yu Rou shook her head, “No... Actually... Perhaps I knew— but forgot about it since Brother Yuan always treated me like a real sister, and I was very young back then. Maybe I didn’t want to believe it and tricked myself into thinking that he was my real brother. Even I don’t know anymore.”

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Chapter 655: Yu Rou's Decision

“Sorry for keeping this a secret from you two, Meixiu...” Yu Rou sighed a moment later.

“No, I should be the one apologizing. There have been many moments where I pondered about telling you. But seeing you so happy to be his ‘little sister’, I didn’t want to ruin it for you or him by tearing apart your status as brother and sister.” Meixiu shook her head.

“I understand. After all, that’s also why I didn’t reveal the fact that I knew about it. I didn’t want to ruin our relationship as siblings.” Yu Rou smiled.

She then turned to look at Chu Liuxiang and continued, “Can you tell me about Brother Yuan’s life in the orphanage? I have always been curious, but I was also too scared to ask about it since that would give everything away.”

“Of course! It would be my pleasure!”

To Yu Rou’s surprise, Chu Liuxiang didn’t object to her request, as she was certain that Chu Liuxiang would rather keep everything a secret just to tease her.

“But in return, you’ll tell me about Brother Yuan’s life in the Yu Family. The good memories. I already know all of the bad ones, after all.” Chu Liuxiang added.

And for the rest of the journey, Chu Liuxiang and Yu Rou would share their memories with Yuan to each other, quickly becoming friends.

‘What a surprise...’

This left Meixiu profoundly surprised, as she did not expect the two of them would suddenly become friends. In fact, she had expected some sort of rivalry between them, especially since Yu Rou is very protective when it comes to Yuan being with other women.

A few hours later, they arrived at Pang City, and Feng Yuxiang descended directly in front of the Luo Family's manor.

"W-Welcome back, Seniors!" The guards bowed to them.

A couple of minutes later, they went to Yuan's room.

"Young Master, I have returned from the trip." Feng Yuxiang knocked on the door.

"Brother Yuan! I am here!" Yu Rou shouted in an excited voice.

Yuan appeared before them shortly after hearing their voices.

"Hello, Yu Rou. It's been a while—"

Yu Rou pounced on Yuan and hugged him tightly before he could even finish his sentence.

"I have missed you very much, brother!"

Yuan returned her hug, "I missed you too."

"Anyways, why did you want to meet with us so suddenly?" Yuan asked her once they entered his room.

"Well, I was worried about you."

"Worried about me?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"Of course! I heard that you'd killed thousands of people and exterminated an entire sect! Is that true?! I couldn't believe it when I heard it! After all, there's no way that you could do such a thing!"

“Oh... So it’s about the Blood Sect, huh?” Yuan sighed.

“Brother... You...”

“It’s true. I destroyed the Blood Sect and killed thousands of their disciples,” he said with a serious expression.

Yu Rou’s eyes widened.

Although she already knew in her heart that it was true, she had to hear it from Yuan’s mouth to completely believe it.

“Are... Are you okay...?” Yu Rou asked him after snapping out of her daze.

“Yes, I am fine.” He nodded.

“Why...? Why would you do such a thing? It’s not like you...” Yu Rou stared at him in the eyes with a worried gaze.

“The Blood Sect is an evil sect. They have killed many innocent people, and they would have continued to do so if someone didn’t stop them. They also killed one of my first friends in this world, so I took it upon myself to stop them. I guess you can even call it revenge.”

“I wasn’t expecting to destroy their sect, but fortunately for me, their Sect Leader had gathered all of his disciples, allowing me to wipe them out in one go.”

“I don’t expect you to understand my feelings, but if you’d met the Blood Sect— these insane beasts, you would also want to destroy them.”

“Brother...”

Yu Rou was speechless, but she could tell that her brother had changed drastically since the last time she saw him.

He no longer looked as immature and innocent as before, and there was even a hint of coldness deep within his eyes that she almost didn’t notice.

“If my actions had disappointed you, I am sorry, but I had to do what was necessary to save this city and other innocent people.”

Yu Rou closed her eyes and took a deep breath, silently digesting all of this information.

“It’s not that I am disappointed, brother. I am just surprised— flabbergasted that you had the capabilities to do such a thing. In the end, this is just a game, and it’s not illegal to kill others in this world, so I completely understand.”

Hearing Yu Rou’s words, Yuan wanted to tell her that Cultivation Online might exist somewhere in their universe, but he decided to tell her about it later since he didn’t want to overwhelm her with so much information so quickly.

“Thank you for understanding, Yu Rou.”

“What are your plans now?” Yu Rou asked something later.

“We’re going to climb the Stairway to Heaven and transcend to the next realm. Do you want to come with us? We have more room if you want to follow us.” Yuan said.

Yu Rou pondered for a moment before shaking her head, “I wanted to follow you before, but I think it would be better to stay down here for now.”

“Eh? Why?” Yuan asked in a slightly dumbfounded voice.

“First of all, most of my time is now spent on training myself, and when I do have the time to play, I’d rather just rest. In other words, I have no time to be in this world.” Yu Rou sighed.

“You sound like an old man who’s devoted all his time to work.” Chu Liuxiang suddenly said.

“Well, I cannot deny that.” Yu Rou shrugged.

“But that’s not the only reason why I want to stay down here. Let me explain.” Yu Rou continued.

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Chapter 656: Just Joking

“The other reason why I don’t want to ascend has connections to the first reason. Since I don’t have time to play, my progression will barely move, so even if I ascend, I will only be a hindrance to you all. Do you understand?”

“It’s like sending a low-level player to a place filled with high-level monsters. I won’t be able to do anything by myself if you leave my side even for a moment, brother. And I do not expect you to wait for me, as that would be a waste of time.” Yu Rou sighed.

“But I can help you progress faster with treasures! You won’t be a burden to me!” Yuan said.

“Don’t even bother trying to convince me, brother. I have already decided to stay down here. Furthermore, I won’t be alone since I will have Xia Jingyi by my side.”

After a moment of silence, Yuan sighed, “Alright. Fine. I won’t try to convince you anymore. However, just know that once I leave, it will be incredibly hard for us to meet in this world again since I cannot come down to the Lower Heavens whenever I please.”

“It’s not like we cannot see each other in the other world.” Yu Rou smiled.

“Anyways, I have to wake up early tomorrow for training, so I won’t be able to stay here for much longer. Let’s talk to each other until I have to leave, okay?”

Yuan nodded, “I want to hear more about your faction.”

“Of course! It’s a really great place. Everyone there is very nice to each other, and it feels like I’d suddenly gained a new family. Although training

is hard at times, my cultivation has improved by leaps and bounds since I started training there.”

Yu Rou proceeded to recall her last couple of weeks as a member of the Eternal Lotuses.

She told Yuan her daily routines, her training schedules, and even some of Xia Jingyi’s experiences there.

“It sounds like a great place. I should visit there one day.” Yuan smiled.

“How about your faction, brother? You created one, right?”

“Yes, that’s right. It’s called the Demon Sealing Faction.”

“W-Wait... Demon Sealing Faction?” Yu Rou looked at him with wide eyes, as the name of his faction implies their purpose.

“Yes. There are still demons left in our world, and our purpose is to exterminate all of them.” Yuan explained to her.

“T-That’s too dangerous! I won’t let you endanger your life like this!” Yu Rou exclaimed.

“I know it’s dangerous, but I am the only person in the world who can fight these demons— at least for now. If I don’t fight them, they will wreak havoc around the world and kill many innocent people.”

“T-That’s...” Yu Rou was left speechless by his selfless words.

“And when I imagine one of these innocent people being you— or any of my friends... I don’t want another friend to die again, much less my own sister...”

Yu Rou closed her eyes and took a few deep breaths.

“I understand, brother. However, you must be careful.”

“Definitely.” Yuan nodded with a gentle smile.

After talking to each other for a few hours, Yu Rou hugged Yuan before logging off the game.

Yuan went to speak with Lord Luo and his family afterward, “I will be leaving this place tomorrow. Thank you for everything.”

“We should be the one thanking you, Daoist Yuan.” Lord Luo bowed to him.

“Yuan... Will we be able to see each other again in the future?” Luo Li asked him.

“I will try my best to make it happen.”

“It’s a promise.”

Yuan looked around and asked, “Where’s your brother? I haven’t seen him since I got here.”

“He’s at his sect right now, but I will let him know that you’d visited us.” Luo Ling said.

Yuan nodded and logged off shortly after to have dinner.

“Your sister is a special one. Nothing like I had anticipated.” Chu Liuxiang said to Yuan after dinner.

“Really? Were you able to get along with her?”

“I was. We had a lot of interesting conversations on our way to you. Hell, we can even be considered friends at this point!”

“That’s good to hear.” Yuan smiled.

“If we’re going to start a family together, it’s essential for me to have a good relationship with your family, after all.” Chu Liuxiang chuckled.

Wang Ming and the others looked at Chu Liuxiang with wide eyes.

Although they were already aware of Chu Liuxiang's feelings for Yuan, they didn't expect her to be so open about it.

After dinner, everyone returned to their rooms.

"What a lucky bastard... But it's not shocking for a genius like him to have so many beauties by his side..." Wang Ming sighed out loud as he walked back to his room.

"If you're jealous, why don't you find your own girlfriends? It's not like you have no hope." Wang Bingbing said to him.

"Nah. Too much work. And I don't have the time to pamper them." Wang Ming shrugged.

"What about you, sister? Why don't you become Yuan's woman as well?"

"Now why on earth would I do that?" Wang Bingbing frowned.

"For starters, it'll benefit our family greatly. He's also very talented and a good fellow in general. If I were in your shoes, I would already be trying to acquire a slot beside him before all of the slots are taken."

"What? You don't like him or something?" Wang Ming then asked.

"..."

Wang Bingbing sighed after a moment of silence, "That's not the issue. He already has two women— Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang by his side, one for each arm. They are also extremely pretty and talented if you haven't noticed already. I won't stand a chance against them."

Wang Ming stared at his elder sister with a look of disbelief on his face.

"Y-You actually thought about becoming his woman? I was just joking with you! Hahaha!" He burst out laughing, causing Wang Bingbing's face to flush with redness.

“G-Grab your sword and meet me outside! I’m going to kill you!” Wang Bingbing pointed at him with her hand trembling.

Wang Ming casually shrugged, “Are you kidding me? We just ate, so I am a little sleepy. If you want to fight, we can do it tomorrow.”

After saying that, he went into his room and locked it, leaving Wang Bingbing speechless.

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Chapter 657: Nightmare

After returning to his room, Yuan went to his closet and retrieved a basket of medicine.

“Are those the medicine you’d acquired from the Jaded Garden? Do you plan on tempering your body tonight?” Chu Liuxiang asked him when she saw the basket.

“Yes. Do you want to join me?” Yuan asked her.

“Is that even a question? Of course, I want to join you!” Chu Liuxiang wasted no time removing her clothes, stripping herself naked before Yuan could even prepare the bath.

“I haven’t even prepared the bath. You should put your clothes back on unless you want to catch a cold.” Yuan said to her.

Chu Liuxiang chuckled, “I haven’t caught a cold ever since I became a Cultivator. I don’t think Cultivators can even catch colds.”

“Anyways, I already took my clothes off. I will just wait under the blankets until you’re done. You can join me at any time.” Chu Liuxiang said as she entered the bed.

Yuan couldn’t help but smile at Chu Liuxiang’s behavior that reminded him of Elder Shan from the Dragon Essence Temple, and they both give off similar vibes.

Half an hour later, once the bathtub was prepared, Yuan entered the green water with Chu Liuxiang.

“Have you ever tempered your body before?” Yuan asked her.

“I have,” she calmly replied.

“Really? Where does the Chu Family obtain their medicine?”

“They grow them just like the Six Spiritual Families, but they use a different method. It’s even a little stronger than the medicine we’re currently using. I will ask Sebastian to bring some over tomorrow if you’re interested.”

“If you don’t mind.”

“Anything for you, Brother Yuan...”

“Actually, can I just call you Yuan from now on?” Chu Liuxiang suddenly said.

“Eh? Of course, you can. But why the sudden change?” Yuan asked.

“Calling you ‘brother’ is obviously something very special for Yu Rou, so I decided to not take that away from her. She was the only one in the Yu Family who cared enough to take care of you, after all.”

Chu Liuxiang explained, and she continued, “Furthermore, it feels weird trying to start a family with my ‘brother’.”

“You can call me whatever you want.” Yuan smiled.

“Really? Then can I call you darling? I find that more fitting than just Yuan! It’s more unique as well!”

“D-Darling? I think that’s a little bit too much...”

“Eh?! Please! Everybody already calls you ‘Yuan’, and I want you to feel special when we’re together!”

Yuan sighed.

After pondering for a moment, he gave up and said, “Fine, but you can only call me that when we’re alone. It will feel awkward if you call me that in

front of everyone.”

“Don’t worry, I will wait until we’re officially a family before I start doing that.” Chu Liuxiang smiled.

The two of them casually spoke to each other while absorbing the medicine. Because both of them were used to tempering their body in stronger medicine, they were both felt relaxed enough to chat while tempering their body at the same time.

“You spoke with my sister today, right? What did you talk about?” Yuan suddenly asked.

“That’s a secret.”

“You can’t even tell me a little?”

“I cannot. We promised Yu Rou that we would keep it a secret, after all.”

“Since you made a promise, I won’t ask anymore. Let’s change the topic. Your cultivation base in Cultivation Online... I was surprised when I saw it.”

“Second Level Spirit Apprentice? I didn’t think it would be that low...”

“Meixiu also said the same thing, you know?” Chu Liuxiang smiled.

And she continued, “Is it really that bad? I am already a Spirit Master in this world. Why do I need to cultivate in that world as well? I don’t have enough time in this life to cultivate two bodies at once.”

“Like you’d said, you’re already a Spirit Master in this world, which is the limit of this world. Your progress will now be incredibly slow, and it could take years to increase even a single level. However, that’s not the case for Cultivation Online. In that world, you can surpass Spirit Master and become a Spirit Grandmaster and so much more.”

“Furthermore, some of the things you do in Cultivation Online, such as consuming treasures, will somehow affect you in this world. What if

increasing your cultivation base there also affects us but we just don't know how... yet?"

"D-Darling... That... That actually makes a lot of sense! You're a genius! I never thought about it like that until you mentioned it! You have opened my eyes! I will focus on my cultivation in Cultivation Online now!"

"R-Really?"

"Yes. As you'd mentioned, I have already reached the limits of this world, so there's almost no point for me to continue cultivating this body. Instead, I should cultivate my second body! It might even help us break through the limits of this world and reach an unprecedented level!"

"Unfortunately, it'll require a lot of resources if I want to catch up to Meixiu, much less you."

"I could ask my family for help, but that would require me to return home and I don't want to do that." Chu Liuxiang sighed.

"I can help you if you want. After eliminating the Blood Sect, I managed to acquire a bunch of treasures and spirit stones, especially their Sect Master's spatial ring. He was loaded with treasures!"

Chu Liuxiang nodded, "Since you offered, I won't be humble, Yua—darling! In return, you can do whatever you want to me tonight— and every night after that!"

The two of them left the bathroom about three hours later after they cleaned out the medicine bath.

Yuan went to sleep shortly after without taking up Chu Liuxiang's offer, but it wasn't like she didn't anticipate it. In fact, it would be shocking if he actually did anything to her.

In his sleep, Yuan had a dream— a nightmare. He was underneath a crimson sky, there were mountains upon mountains of corpses around him, and he stood in a sea of blood that nearly reached his knees.

Yuan felt a presence behind him, so he turned to take a look, and as he'd expected, the handsome man was there, casually sitting on one of the corpse mountains while staring at the red sky with a dazed face.

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Chapter 658: Evil God

“How do you like the scenery? Does it make your heart pound with excitement?” The handsome man suddenly asked him without looking away from the red sky.

Yuan coldly snorted, “Why are you showing up now? You didn’t show up when I asked you to fight the Blood Sect.”

The handsome man turned to look at him with red eyes and showed a grim smile, “Are you still angry that I killed those ants for you? You must have wanted to kill them yourself, but you didn’t have the courage, so I had to give you a slight push.”

Yuan frowned at his words.

“Angry? Of course, I am angry! However, it’s not because you killed those people! I am angry because you possessed my body without my permission!”

“First it was the Divine Paragon, now it’s you!”

Yuan expressed his concerns regarding their possession.

And to his surprise, the handsome man actually began laughing.

“Possessed? You think we possessed you? That is incorrect. We’re not ghosts.”

“Then how do you explain what happened?!”

“It’s simple. You awakened your memories and began acting as though you were that person. You were the one who called upon us— not the other way

around. The Divine Paragon took over your body because you wanted to defeat the demon. I took over your body because you wanted to kill those ants. It's as simple as that."

"N-No way..."

"It's the truth. We may have lived different lives, but in the end, we're all the same person. Don't be angry at me— us. It just means you're angry at yourself."

"..."

After a moment of silence, Yuan spoke in a questioning tone, "And who are you supposed to be?"

The handsome man suddenly stood up and turned to face him.

"People used to call me the Evil God. You can call me that as well. It has a nice ring to it."

"E-Evil God...?" Yuan was speechless.

"What did you do to acquire such an obnoxious title?"

"I killed people— a lot of people. If you piled all of the people I killed in one spot, it could easily reach the heavens. Don't you remember?" The handsome man showed a cold smug.

"Why? Why did you kill these people?"

"Why not? They were an eyesore, so I killed them, just like how you killed those disciples from the Blood Sect."

"That's completely different!"

"No, it's not, but you already know that. Good luck trying to convince yourself, little Evil God."

The Evil God disappeared after that sentence, and the scenery changed, showing Yuan some of the Evil God's memories.

However, none of these memories were pleasant, as they were all scenes of the Evil God slaying people. There was not a single memory that did not end up in someone dying to his hands.

Yuan looked at his own hands that were trembling in disbelief.

'I used to be the Evil God...? What an unfunny joke...' He sighed inwardly.

Eventually, the bloody memories ended, and the handsome man reappeared before him again.

However, it was not the Evil God.

"What do you think about your latest incarnation?" He asked with a mysterious smile hanging on his face.

"An unpleasant fellow that has no morals. He's completely different compared to you and the Divine Paragon."

The handsome man laughed out loud before speaking, "That's not entirely correct. In fact, we're not that different from each other. The Divine Paragon, the Evil God, me— and even you."

"What? That's not possible! I would never become an Evil God! He killed people because they were an eyesore!" Yuan frowned.

"You're only saying that because you don't remember everything. And if I recall correctly, didn't you kill a few thousand people without batting an eye not long ago? Why did you kill them? Because they threatened the safety of your friends?"

"That's right! If I didn't kill them, the Pang City would've been in danger!"

"Once again you're lying to me— to yourself. You killed them because they were an eyesore— because they were an inconvenience. Everything else is

just an excuse.”

The handsome man turned around and began walking away.

“If you want to learn more about yourself— about the reason for your existence, follow your bloodline.

“My bloodline...? You mean the Immortal Monarch Bloodline? What is so special about it?”

The handsome man shrugged at his question before disappearing from his sight.

Yuan woke up the next moment to find his body soaked in cold sweats.

“My bloodline, huh...”

“Are you okay, darling?” Chu Liuxiang’s voice suddenly resounded beside him.

“Eh? Sorry, did I wake you up?”

“Well, you were just squirming around in your sleep, and it also looked like you were in pain.”

“I had a nightmare...” He sighed.

“Do you want to talk about it?”

“It’s nothing serious. I saw many people getting killed. That’s all.”

“I see...”

“Anyways, I am going to clear my mind. You can go back to sleep.”

“Alright.”

Yuan left the bed and went to the bathroom to rinse the sweat off his body.

Once he came back out, he went onto the balcony and proceeded to sit there until it was time for breakfast.

After breakfast, Yuan went inside Cultivation Online and waited for Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang to show up.

When everyone was gathered, Yuan said his goodbyes to the Luo Family.

“Yuan! Do you mind if we repeat what we did last time?” Luo Li suddenly asked him.

“Last time?” Yuan raised his eyebrows in a puzzled manner.

“You know... The kiss...” Luo Li reminded him in a bashful manner.

“Oh, that. I don’t mind.” He casually nodded.

Luo Li and Luo Ling wasted no time and gave him a kiss on his cheeks.

“Goodbye, Yuan! We hope to see you again in the future!”

Yuan left Pang City with the others shortly after.

After leaving the city, Yuan turned to look at Xiao Hua and asked, “Where is the Stairway to Heaven?”

“Follow me, Brother Yuan. Xiao Hua will take you there,” she said with an eager smile.

Chapter 659: Encountering the Gu Family

“Where the fuck is that bitch, Min Li?! We have been waiting here for almost a week! She should be here by now!” Gu Tao shouted in an angry voice when he lost his patience.

“Do you think we were fooled by the Min Family?” He then asked his father, who was sitting beside him inside the carriage.

“That’s not possible. He wouldn’t lie about something like this. It would only damage his family’s reputation, and you know how much we value our face. Furthermore, this is Min Li that we’re talking about. They wouldn’t sacrifice their family’s reputation for her. Why do you think they sold her to us in the first place?”

“That makes sense... However, that doesn’t change the fact that Min Li isn’t here. We came here immediately after leaving the Min Family, so there’s no way that we’d missed her.” Gu Tao said.

“That’s also not possible. I had spoken to the people here. None of them have seen Min Li, and she’s one eye-catching girl.”

“Then how long are we going to wait? We cannot stay here forever, not to mention that wedding that is supposed to be in three days!” Gu Tao sighed out loud.

“There’s nothing we can do but wait.”

It was at this moment the Gu Family noticed a group of individuals approaching their direction, and all but one of them were kingdom-toppling

beauties.

However, Gu Tao only had one person in his eyes— a young lady with a familiar face!

“Wow, so that is the Stairway to Heaven, huh? It’s much grander than I’d anticipated.” Yuan mumbled in awe as he gazed upon the massive staircase that hovered in the air not far in the distance.

There were only a total of 9 steps on this staircase, but it was so massive that it filled the sky and seemed like it was created for giants, and there was a beautiful golden door at the end of the ninth step.

“I have never seen such a big staircase before. It’s almost as though it was created for giants.” Chu Liuxiang mumbled in a dazed voice.

“Speaking of giants... Do they exist in the cultivation world?” Yuan asked.

“They do.” Feng Yuxiang nodded.

“However, they only exist in the upper heavens now.”

“Have you seen one before?” Meixiu asked her.

“I have met a few when I was still living up there. They’re all incredibly powerful beings with unrivaled strength. They are also born with near-indestructible bodies.”

“I want to meet one now.” Yuan smiled.

“By the way, that’s not the real Stairway to Heaven.” Feng Yuxiang suddenly said.

“Then where is the real one?”

“It’s inside that golden door,” she said.

“Is that so...”

“Yuan...” Min Li suddenly tucked his robes.

“Hm? What’s the matter?”

“Do you see that large carriage in front of us? It’s the Gu Family,” she said with a worried frown.

“Gu Family? The family you were supposed to marry into?” Yuan asked for confirmation.

“Yes.” Min Li nodded.

“What are they doing here? Do you think they’re here to find you?”

“I cannot think of any other reason for them to be here. It’s too much of a coincidence.”

“You don’t have to worry about them. I will protect you if they try anything funny.” Yuan said.

And right as they were about to pass the carriage, someone suddenly shouted, “Halt!”

The next moment, Gu Tao and his father, alongside many guards surrounded them.

“Min Li! How dare you run away from our marriage! Hurry up and come back to the family with me and I will make you the happiest woman in this world!” Gu Tao stepped forward and patted his chest.

“I refuse. I left the Min Family for a reason, Gu Tao. I’d rather kill myself than join your family.” Min Li sneered.

“Let’s not make things difficult, Min Li.” The middle-aged man standing behind Gu Tao suddenly spoke.

“Even if you run away from the Min Family, where can you go?”

“Where I go is none of your business!”

The middle-aged man turned to look at the Stairway to Heaven behind him and laughed.

“Do you really think you have the capabilities to ascend through the stairway as a Spirit Warrior? Have you lost your damn mind?”

“Who said that she’ll be climbing by herself?” Yuan suddenly stepped forward, standing between Min Li and the Gu Family.

“And who the hell are you? Do you know who we are?” Gu Tao immediately frowned at Yuan’s presence that felt threatening for some reason.

“My name is Yuan. And you’re one of the Seven Legacy Families, right?”

“If you know, get the fuck out of the way before you lose your life. I am trying to speak with my woman here.” Gu Tao narrowed his eyes.

Because they have been waiting at the Stairway to Heaven for the past week, they have not heard about Yuan’s most recent achievement yet. If they knew Yuan had eliminated the Blood Sect by himself, they wouldn’t dare to disrespect him in such a manner.

“And you must have a death wish, speaking to my Young Master in such a foul manner.” Feng Yuxiang tried to step forward but was blocked by Yuan.

“So what if you’re one of the Seven Legacy Families? Min Li has already stated that she won’t marry into your family. Furthermore, she will be ascending the Stairway to Heaven with me.”

Veins began popping up on Gu Tao’s forehead.

“Min Li, don’t tell me that you’d abandoned your family and risk offending mine just to be together with this nobody? Have you gone insane?!” Gu Tao growled in a cold voice.

“If he’s a nobody, then you’re less than trash, Gu Tao. You have no idea who you’re messing with.” Min Li shook her head.

The middle-aged man then said, “I have had enough of this nonsense. If you don’t want to follow us back willingly, we’ll force you! Get her!”

The guards immediately pointed their weapons at Yuan and the others.

“I have also had enough with your Gu Family!” Feng Yuxiang suddenly shouted, releasing her Spirit Grandmaster cultivation base.

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Chapter 660: Take His Cultivation Away!

‘S-Spirit Grandmaster! She’s a Spirit Grandmaster!’ The middle-aged man cried inwardly, shocked by Feng Yuxiang’s cultivation base.

“If you dare move, I will kill you.” Feng Yuxiang said to them with an overbearing aura around her.

However, Gu Tao’s father was also a Spirit Grandmaster, so he didn’t immediately back down.

“Who are you?” He asked her with a slight frown.

“Feng Yuxiang.”

“What?! Madam Feng from the Golden Phoenix Bazaar?!”

Although he has never personally gone to her store before, his Gu Family has purchased many treasures from her place before.

“Impossible! What are you doing in this place?!”

“My business is none of your business. However, your business on the other hand...” Feng Yuxiang narrowed her eyes.

“How dare you treat my Young Master in such a manner?! Courting death!”

Feng Yuxiang began approaching Gu Tao while emitting strong killing intent.

“F-Father! Help me! Kill this bitch for me!” Gu Tao immediately hid behind his father’s back.

Although he could sense Feng Yuxiang’s threatening aura, he doesn’t actually know Feng Yuxiang’s identity, nor was he aware of her cultivation base.

“Oh? It’s been a while since someone cursed at me.” A malicious grin appeared on Feng Yuxiang’s face.

“M-Madam Feng, please excuse this foolish son of mine!”

“Father? What are you doing?” Gu Tao looked at him with a confused face, as his father was a Spirit Grandmaster.

“Shut up! You have no idea who you’re standing before right now!” His father suddenly slapped him in the face, sending his body flying.

This shocked the guards from the Gu Family. This is their first time seeing Gu Tao being struck by his own father, something that doesn’t happen even during training.

“You think that’s enough to seek forgiveness? I won’t be satisfied until he stops breathing!”

“Madam Feng, please have mercy! We’ll forget about the wedding and leave immediately!”

The father knew that offending Feng Yuxiang was akin to death in the Lower Heavens, especially with her vast connections around the world. Unless they called for help from the Gu Family in the upper heavens, there was nothing they could do to stop her.

“...”

Feng Yuxiang didn’t say anything, and she turned to look at Yuan for his opinions on the matter. As much as she wanted to kill Gu Tao right there and then, she didn’t want to upset Yuan, who didn’t like violence.

“Young Master, it’s your call.” She said to him.

Yuan turned to look at Gu Tao, who was still struggling on the floor, for a good moment before closing his eyes and speaking in a low voice, “Feng Feng, doesn’t this situation remind you of another situation that played out very similarly?”

Feng Yuxiang pondered for a moment before speaking, “Are you talking about the Du Brothers from before?”

Yuan nodded and continued, “He doesn’t deserve to die, but he needs to be taught a lesson. Take his cultivation away.”

Yuan’s words stunned everyone there including his own people.

After snapping out of her daze, Feng Yuxiang responded with a beaming smile on her face, “With pleasure, Young Master!”

She turned to face Gu Tao and began approaching him.

“Madam Feng! Please! If you take away his cultivation, you might as well kill him!” Gu Tao’s father subconsciously blocked her path.

“Get out of my way, Patriarch Gu, unless you want to lose your cultivation too.” Feng Yuxiang narrowed her eyes that had turned golden at him, sending shivers down his back.

Patriarch Gu knew in his heart that it was impossible to stop Feng Yuxiang. However, he had another option.

He turned to look at Yuan and said, “Please! Stop her! Have mercy, Daoist Yuan—”

It was at this moment Patriarch Gu realized something.

‘Wait... Yuan? He’s that genius from the Dragon Essence Temple?!’

Patriarch Gu could recall ordering his family to recruit Yuan into their family at all cost, yet he’d managed to offend Yuan.

“Young Master Yuan! It was our fault for not recognizing you! We shouldn’t have tried to force Min Li to marry into our family! Please! If you cripple Gu Tao, he will be completely useless and might as well be dead!”

Yuan scoffed at his words and said, “Cripple? Now that’s an exaggeration. He may lose his ability to cultivate, but he’ll still be able to function as a normal human.”

“Please! Young Master Yuan! I beg of you!” Patriarch Gu suddenly lowered his body and knelt on the ground in front of Yuan.

Seeing this, Yuan said, “Feng Feng, wait a second.”

“Eh?” Feng Yuxiang stopped two steps away from the terrified Gu Tao.

After a moment of silence, Yuan extended his hand and spoke, “I am willing to forgive you and your son, but you’ll have to do me a favor in return.”

“Really?! Whatever you need!” Patriarch Gu’s eyes flickered with hope.

“You see, I have purchased a house very recently, so I have no money now. If you donate me some of your wealth, I will forgive you. I’m a generous man, so I will only ask for all of your spatial rings and storage pouches.”

Patriarch Gu’s jaw dropped when he heard Yuan’s words. It was something he least expected!

As the patriarch of the Gu Family, Patriarch Gu naturally has plenty of wealth on him. In fact, he normally carries the family’s most valuable treasures on his body since he believes that it would be safer than keeping it at home and that nobody would be able to rob him, the patriarch of a Legacy Family!

Seeing Patriarch Gu’s hesitation, Yuan sighed, “I gave you a chance since you begged, and you even said whatever I want, but alas...”

And he continued, “Feng Feng, go ahead and continue whatever you were doing.”

“Yes!”

Feng Yuxiang took the last two steps and arrived in front of Gu Tao.

“W-W-Wait! Why don’t we talk about this?” Patriarch Gu felt like crying, yet he was unable to produce any tears.

“There is nothing to talk about. You lost that chance when you threatened to take Min Li away by force.”

Patriarch Gu gritted his teeth in anger, but he eventually gave up and said, “Fine! I will give them to you!”

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Chapter 661: A Generous Donation From the Gu Family

“Here are my spatial rings and storage pouches! Let my son go now!” Patriarch Gu gritted his teeth and handed over his treasures to Yuan.

Meanwhile, Feng Yuxiang also collected Gu Tao’s spatial rings and storage pouches.

“H-Here you go, Senior Fairy!”

Gu Tao handed all of his possession to Feng Yuxiang without any hesitation. In his mind, nothing in this world was more valuable than his cultivation that took years of effort to build.

After taking his treasures, Feng Yuxiang returned to Yuan’s side and gave them to him.

“Thank you, Feng Feng.”

“C-Can we leave now?” Patriarch Gu asked him, seemingly in a hurry to leave.

“Yes, you can—”

However, before Yuan could finish his sentence, Xiao Hua stepped forward and said, “Wait.”

“What’s the matter?” Yuan looked at her.

She pointed at Patriarch Gu and spoke in a calm voice, “He still has a spatial ring hidden on his body.”

Patriarch Gu's entire body trembled when he heard Xiao Hua's claims.

"T-That's outrageous! I have already given you everything I own! I don't have anything else on me!" He exclaimed in a furious tone.

Yuan frowned and said, "Xiao Hua wouldn't lie to me. If she says you're hiding something, then you're hiding something! I will give you one last chance!"

Patriarch Gu stared at Xiao Hua with killing intent in his gaze.

Feng Yuxiang chuckled and said, "I wouldn't do anything silly if I were you, Patriarch Gu. She's even stronger than me. In fact, she's a Spirit King who came from the upper heavens."

"W-What?! Impossible!"

Xiao Hua didn't say anything and released some of her cultivation base.

'It's real! She's actually a Spirit King! What is a Spirit King doing here?!' Patriarch Gu could feel the blood in his body getting drained when he realized this fact, making his complexion as pale as ghosts.

'Damn! Damn it all! This is all because of the Min Family!'

Patriarch Gu reluctantly retrieved his hidden spatial ring that had all of his most valuable treasures and handed it over to Yuan.

"If you take this from me— from my family, you will definitely regret it! The Gu Family will become your eternal enemy! Think about this carefully one more time!" Patriarch Gu glared at Yuan with red eyes.

Under normal circumstances, he would not surrender this spatial ring even if he had to sacrifice his own son. However, he was before a Spirit King. If he doesn't obey their commands, he could lose his own life, as well as his treasures.

Yuan didn't hesitate to take the spatial ring from his hand and said in a cold voice, "You shouldn't have tried to force Min Li. You deserve this

punishment.”

“Let’s go.” Yuan began walking away after accepting the Gu Family’s generous donation.

The Gu Family could only stand there and watch as they disappear from the scene.

“Fuck! Fuck! Fuck!” Patriarch Gu began destroying whatever was around him in an outburst of anger.

“Father... It’s just a few spatial rings. We have plenty of treasure at home...” Gu Tao tried to calm him down, unaware of what Yuan had really taken away from them.

However, Patriarch Gu slapped him and shouted, “Just a few spatial rings?! Do you have any idea what was inside those spatial rings?! All of our family heritage and secret cultivation techniques are inside that spatial ring!”

“WHAT?!” Gu Tao exclaimed in a shocked voice when he realized the severity of the situation.

“W-Why would you even carry them around with you?! Father! We need to take them back even if we have to risk our lives!”

“You’re dumber than I thought, Gu Tao! They had a Spirit King with them! She’ll kill us before we can even touch them, much less take back our treasures!”

“Then what can we do? We can’t just let them get away with this!”

“We’re going back home! I will contact our Seniors from Spirit Heaven and ask them to avenge us and take back our treasures! We cannot allow them to steal from our Gu Family at all cost!” Patriarch Gu said.

“Thank you for protecting me, Yuan...” Min Li said to him afterward with a rosy face.

“I made a promise, after all.” Yuan smiled.

“Young Master, you were very cool back there. I cannot believe you actually dared to steal from the Gu Family.” Feng Yuxiang chuckled.

“I didn’t steal anything from them. They offered it to me as a donation.” He casually shrugged.

“Anyways, even though I have their spatial rings and storage pouches, I cannot open them since their owners are not dead. What should I do?”

“You can forcefully remove the previous owner’s mark on them, but you’ll need an Array Master to do so. If someone without experience does it and screws up, they risk destroying the spatial ring and the contents inside.”

“I definitely don’t want that to happen. And what’s an Array Master?”

“An Array Master is something like a Formation Expert. They specialize in arrays while Formation Experts specialize in formations.” Feng Yuxiang said.

And she continued, “As for the difference between them... Arrays are small formations that require very little time to cast, allowing Array Masters to use them efficiently and quickly, and creating arrays only require spiritual energy.”

“As for formations, they are much larger in scale that requires preparation and a large number of resources, and they usually require more than one person to activate.”

“In other words, arrays are simple and small formations that can be created and used during a fight while formations are more complex and require preparation before they can be activated.”

The Thousand Swords Formation that was once used by the Flying Sword Sect is considered a formation since it covers the entire sect and requires many people to activate. Arrays, on the other hand, are fundamentally like formations, but they function more like techniques.

“You won’t find any Array Masters in the Lower Heaven, Young Master. Even in the Spirit Heaven, they can be quite rare.” Feng Yuxiang said to him.

“That’s fine. I am not in a hurry to open these spatial rings.” Yuan said.

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Chapter 662: Climbing the Stairway to Heaven

“We have arrived at the Stairway to Heaven.” Feng Yuxiang said as they approached the massive staircase not far away from them.

“It’s quite empty here...”

Yuan had expected there to be more people in this place for some reason, but that didn’t seem to be the case, as there were only a dozen people there including an old man sitting behind a desk right beside the staircase.

“Young Master, speak with that old man whenever you’re ready to challenge the Stairway to Heaven. I will be cheering for you from inside your body since I don’t need to participate in the trials.” Feng Yuxiang said to him before transforming into a glowing orb and entering his body.

“Xiao Hua is confident that Brother Yuan will succeed.” Xiao Hua also entered his body a moment later.

Only Lan Yingying remained, as she didn’t come from the upper heavens like the other two.

“W-Where did they go?” Chu Liuxiang asked in a baffled voice, as this was her first time witnessing such a thing.

“They’re resting inside my body right now,” Yuan said.

“What? How does that even work? Can I enter your body too?” She then asked.

“They can do that because they are my servants.” Yuan smiled.

“Anyways, let’s go speak with that old man.”

The old man sitting behind the desk looked at them and said, “Are you going to challenge the Stairway to Heaven?”

“I am.” Yuan nodded.

“First time?”

“Yes.”

“Take this medallion and enter the door whenever you’re ready. However, you should be aware that not everyone can climb the first nine steps on the staircase.” The old man said.

“What do you mean?”

“Every step on the staircase before the door will emit a certain amount of pressure. If you cannot withstand the pressure, you’ll be kicked off the staircase before you can even challenge it.”

“I understand.”

Yuan then pointed at Meixiu and the others standing behind him, “They are with me. Do they also need a medallion?”

The old man raised his eyebrows and said, “Only one person can challenge the Stairway to Heaven at a time. There is no teaming up.”

“I know. I am helping them ascend.”

“You’re what?!” The old man exclaimed in a shocked voice.

He turned to look at the beautiful ladies standing behind Yuan.

Meixiu, Chu Liuxiang, Lan Yingying, and Min Li. Four people in total. Helping a single person will increase the difficulty of his trials, yet he intends on helping four people ascend? The old man has never encountered such a bold and arrogant person before!

“Are you sure about this, young man? Even if they are your partners and you love them greatly, bringing a single person with you will increase the difficulty of the trials as well as your burden significantly. In the last thousand years, not a single person has managed to ascend while bringing someone else along, and you’re doing four at once.”

Yuan smiled and said, “I am well aware of the risks and increased difficulty. However, even then, I still wish to try.”

The old man sighed after a moment of silence.

He then retrieved four more medallions, but they were in a different color.

“Give these to those that you wish to help ascend,” said the old man as he handed them to Yuan. Even if he wished to decline, he did not have the authority to refuse anyone challenging the Stairway to Heaven. The only thing he can do is try to persuade Yuan to not make any foolish decisions, which failed spectacularly.

After accepting the medallions, Yuan handed them to Meixiu and the others.

“You can start climbing the staircase whenever you’re ready.” The old man said to Yuan a moment later.

In his mind, he was already expecting Yuan to fail the challenge.

‘He’ll regret this decision once he realizes how much wasting four years could hurt one’s cultivation career. Unfortunately, there’s no medicine for regret.’ The old man sighed inwardly.

Sometime later, Yuan approached the staircase with Meixiu and the others, and the spectators there watched with interest.

“Another challenger, huh? How long do you think he’ll last inside?”

“Probably an hour at most.”

Meanwhile, Yuan and the others looked at the staircase with their heads tilted up.

A single step of the staircase was so large that it was as tall as a three-story building, and there were 9 steps in total.

“Do you need some help getting up there?” Yuan looked at Chu Liuxiang, who was only a Spirit Apprentice.

“I do.” She nodded.

“Okay, I will carry you.”

He turned to look at Meixiu next, “What about you?”

“I also need help.”

“Fortunately, I have two arms.” Yuan chuckled.

“Yingying, can you help Min Li?” He asked her.

“It’s okay, I can reach it myself.” Min Li quickly said.

“Then let’s go up.”

Yuan proceeded to hug Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang’s waist in each of his arms before flying onto the first step.

Lan Yingying also flew.

As for Min Li, she was able to jump the height with relative ease.

However, the moment Yuan entered the first step that was a few hundred meters away from the second step, he could feel an intense pressure suddenly appear, making it more difficult for him to move forward.

Although he was able to endure the pressure without any issues, he was worried about the others.

“Are you guys okay?!”

“Huh? I don’t feel anything.” Chu Liuxiang said.

“Eh? Really? You don’t feel the pressure?” Yuan looked at them with wide eyes.

They shook their heads.

“So I am the only one feeling this pressure?” He mumbled in a dumbfounded voice.

Feng Yuxiang’s voice then resounded, “Young Master, don’t forget, you’re essentially climbing the Stairway to Heaven for them, so you will be bearing everything while they don’t experience anything.”

“That makes sense...” Yuan nodded.

“Yuan, I will help them climb the staircase. You need to focus on yourself.” Lan Yingying said to him.

“Okay. Thank you.”

After putting down Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang, Yuan proceeded to make his way towards the second step that was about 200 meters away.

Chapter 663: Entering the Stairway to Heaven

“L-Look at that! There’s more than one person climbing the stairway right now!”

“What?! Is that even possible?! I thought only one person could go at a time!”

“It’s only allowed because one of them is assisting them through the Stairway to Heaven— most likely that young man in the front.”

“Wait... That’s actually a thing? Since when? I have spectated this place for many years but I have never seen such a thing before.”

“That’s because nobody does it. One can help 9 other individuals climb the Stairway to Heaven, but the person doing the climbing will have the burden of the other nine, increasing the difficulty of their climb significantly.”

“Heavens... Climbing alone is already hard enough, yet that person is willing to take 4 other people with him.”

“I don’t blame him. Look at the people he’s helping. All of them are breathtaking beauties that can topple kingdoms with a mere smile! I wouldn’t leave them behind either.”

“If you had to choose between those beauties or ascending, and you can only pick one, which would you pick?”

“The beauties, of course! I’d be willing to stay down here forever just for one of them, much less four!”

While the spectators focused on Meixiu and the others, Yuan reached the second step with barely any effort made.

However, the moment he stepped onto the second step, he felt the pressure bearing down his body suddenly double in strength.

Even though it still wasn't enough to make him sweat, he was worried about the later steps.

About a minute later, he reached the third step, and once again, the pressure on him doubled in strength.

"It's still endurable..." Yuan mumbled to himself as he quickly made his way towards the fourth step.

However, the moment he stepped on the fourth step, Yuan felt the pressure on him triple in strength.

Whoosh!

Yuan lost control over his Qi Manipulation for a moment and nearly lost his ability to fly.

"Are you okay, Yuan?" Lan Yingying asked him.

"Yes, I am fine. I was just a little surprised by how much the pressure increased." He nodded.

A few more moments later, Yuan arrived at the fifth step.

Once again, the pressure tripled in strength.

The pressure on the fifth step was so intense that even ordinary Spirit Grandmasters would have trouble walking, yet Yuan still somehow manages to remain in the air even with all this pressure bearing down on him.

Unfortunately, after reaching the seventh floor, the intensity of the pressure had gotten so powerful that even Yuan was forced to walk the staircase with

his legs.

Once he'd reached the end of the seventh step, he used some of his spiritual energy to boost his legs, allowing him to jump onto the eighth floor.

The pressure's strength on the eighth floor increased by another 3 fold.

Yuan could feel his legs shaking slightly from the pressure that made it felt like he was carrying a large block of metal on his back. However, even with such pressure, it'd only managed to make Yuan break a couple droplets of sweat.

A few minutes later, Yuan conquered the eighth step and stepped foot on the ninth and final step, where the golden door was located at the end.

"You got this, Yuan!" Min Li cheered him from only a few steps behind him, feeling a little guilty for making Yuan take her burden.

Yuan closed his eyes and took a deep breath.

Once his eyes opened again, he began running for the golden door, shockling the spectators.

"He still has this much strength left?!"

"Is it that surprising? The real trials are behind that golden door. These nine steps cannot even be considered the real Stairway to Heaven."

"Even though the staircase isn't the real challenge, you cannot underestimate it, as it still eliminates about ninety percent of challengers that wish to enter the Stairway to Heaven."

A few moments later, Yuan arrived before the golden door, and he could feel the pressure on his body suddenly disappear like smoke.

"Phew, that was a little challenging." He wiped the sweat off his forehead and took a moment to breathe.

“Young Master, the real challenges are behind the door.” Feng Yuxiang’s voice resounded in his mind.

“I know...” He sighed.

“Is everyone here?” Yuan turned around to see Meixiu and the others standing right behind him.

Seeing them nod, Yuan returned to looking at the massive golden doors that didn’t seem like it would budge even if he used all of his strength.

“How do I open this door?” Yuan asked.

“There should be a slot for the medallion.” Xiao Hua said.

Yuan looked around, and sure enough, there was a hole in the middle of the door that seemed to fit his medallion perfectly.

Furthermore, there were 9 other holes that circled around it.

“These are probably for your medallions.” Yuan looked at Meixiu and the others after inserting his medallion into the hole.

Once everyone there had inserted their medallion into a slot, the golden doors suddenly began to open.

Although it didn’t move by much, it had more than enough room for a single person to enter.

However, it was pitch black inside the doors.

“Let’s go! To Spirit Heaven!” Yuan was the first to move, entering the golden doors a moment later.

Lan Yingying immediately followed behind Yuan and became the second person to enter the Stairway to Heaven followed by Min Li, Chu Liuxiang, and last but not least, Meixiu.

Once everyone was inside, the golden doors closed behind them.

After entering the Stairway to Heaven, Yuan looked around with his divine sense since he couldn't see anything in the dark with his eyes, but that also turned out to be useless.

"I cannot see anything. What about you guys?" Yuan asked the others behind him.

However, nobody responded to him.

"Meixiu? Lulu? Yingying? Hello?" Yuan turned around, but there was nobody there.

"Guys? Feng Feng? Xiao Hua?"

He tried calling them again since he was certain that they'd entered the Stairway to Heaven with him, but there was still no response, almost as though they'd disappeared and he was completely alone.

It was at this moment a voice suddenly resounded in this void.

"Master?"

It was a clear and childish voice that he'd never heard before, yet it sounded oddly nostalgic for some reason.

"Who's there?" He called back.

"Master? Is that really you?"

The voice responded, and Yuan could see a faint light suddenly appear in the distance.

Chapter 664: Master of the Stairway to Heaven

Yuan swallowed nervously as he watched the faint light gradually approach his direction.

“Master... Is it really you?” The childish voice continued to resound in the darkness.

“I think you’re mistaking me for someone else. This is my first time in this place.” Yuan said.

“No...”

Once the light was right in front of him, it started transforming until it took the shape of a human with a child-like figure.

A few moments later, a cute little girl with long, glistening black hair that dragged on the floor stood before him.

She stared at him intensely with her sharp golden eyes and continued to speak, “While you have a different appearance, your soul is the same. You are definitely my Master. I will never mistake my Master for someone else.”

“You don’t remember me, Master?” She asked him after a moment of silence.

Yuan narrowed his eyes at this little girl and sighed inwardly, ‘She’s definitely talking about one of my past lives, right?’

After another moment of silence, Yuan asked, “Who or what are you?”

“Tian’er is the guardian of Stairway to Heaven.”

“Guardian? Like its Master?”

“No, Tian’er is merely a guardian. I protect this place and uphold its integrity. Master... You are the real Master of the Stairway to Heaven. You really don’t remember?”

“What? I am the Master of this place?” Yuan was left baffled by this information.

Just what kind of person was he in his past life? How did he become the Master of the Stairway to Heaven that connects the Nine Heavens?

“Alright... Before we continue this conversation, where did my friends go? They entered this place with me.” Yuan asked about Meixiu and the others.

“They were transported to another place as spectators because they are not participating in the ascension. They will be able to watch you clear the trials once it begins,” she said.

“I see... That’s relieving to hear.” Yuan released a sigh of relief after learning that they were safe and sound.

“Okay, let’s get back to our conversation— Can they also hear me right now?” He suddenly asked.

“No, they cannot hear us right now.”

Yuan nodded and continued, “Can you tell me the name of your Master?”

“Tian Yang,” she quickly responded.

“I knew it...” Yuan sighed again.

Tian Yang was the name of the handsome man in his dream— the first one he ever met.

“You probably won’t believe me when I say this, but I am actually a reincarnation of Tian Yang, hence why I have the same soul as him...”

Tian’er didn’t react to his words and spoke in a calm voice, “I believe the Master.”

“Wait... Since you knew my past self, can you tell me about him? I am missing some—a lot of my memories because of my reincarnation, so it’ll be great if you can refresh some of my memories.”

Tian’er shook her head and said, “I don’t know much about Master—perhaps even less than you since the Master never spoke of his life outside this world.”

“If that’s the case, can you tell me what you know? Anything will do—even your relationship with him.”

Tian’er nodded, “The Master created me after becoming the Master of the Stairway to Heaven, and I have been tasked with guarding this place ever since then. He also gave me the name Tian’er, his surname, as a way to symbolize his creation.”

“What do you mean you were created?” Yuan raised his eyebrows.

However, she merely tilted her head in a puzzled manner, seemingly unable to explain it.

“How were you created?” Yuan changed his wording.

“The Master snapped his fingers and created me,” she replied.

“Uhh... So you’re not really human?”

She shook her head, “My form consists mostly of the Master’s spiritual energy, so I am neither human nor living.”

“I see... That’s very interesting...”

Yuan suddenly realized something.

“Wait a second... If I am the Master of the Stairway to Heaven, does this mean I don’t need to take the trial to ascend?”

Tian’er nodded, “That is correct. As the Master of the Stairway to Heaven, you can use the treasure as you will.”

“That’s great—”

However, Tian’er continued, “But Master— Tian Yang also said that I cannot allow anyone to ascend if they have never completed the trial before — even if it’s the Master himself.”

Yuan raised his eyebrows.

Why would his past self make this rule that also affects himself? Did his past self predict that he would reincarnation and challenge the Stairway to Heaven in the future?

“It’s unfortunate, but I’m also relieved that I cannot just skip the trials. I have been anticipating doing them for a while now, and skipping them would ruin my fun.” Yuan smiled.

“Anyways, what else can I do in this place as its Master? Can I adjust the difficulty of my trials? What about the rules? Can I change that as well?”

“You can do all of that, but you can only do it when you are not actively challenging the Stairway to Heaven.”

“I understand. Anyways, I have been standing around for long enough. Let’s get the trials started. We can talk more later.” Yuan said a moment later.

Tian’er nodded before disappearing into the void.

A few moments later, Yuan could see a staircase slowly being revealed before him.

The staircase was semi-transparent and was glistening like the sea when being struck by sunlight, and unlike the one outside, this staircase was

definitely made for humans.

Yuan began climbing this staircase without hesitation, and with every step he took, another step would appear at the end of the staircase.

It was unknown how long he walked this staircase for, but he gave up counting after walking 500 steps.

The staircase eventually stopped extending diagonally and began extending horizontally, creating a smooth path for him to walk on.

After walking for a minute, Yuan could see a massive arena in the distance, and the path would lead him to this arena.

Once he stepped foot on this arena, the staircase behind him disappeared, and a semi-transparent wall would cover the whole arena like a closed stadium.

Tian'er's voice resounded a moment later.

“Welcome to the first trial in the Stairway to Heaven, Master.”

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Chapter 665: Stairway to Heaven's First Trial

After entering the Stairway to Heaven, Meixiu and the others found themselves transported to this empty room that somehow had a small pond resting in the center.

“W-Where are we? Where’s Yuan?!” Chu Liuxiang asked in a slightly panicked manner.

“Calm down, we’re currently in the spectators’ area.” Feng Yuxiang said.

“Since we’re not participating in the trial, we were transported somewhere where we cannot disturb the Young Master.”

“I see...”

Meixiu and Min Li looked around with a bewildered face, as they had never seen such scenery before.

Although they were inside a ‘room’, the walls were almost transparent, and the background was a starry sky with tiny lights flickering in the distance. The floor seemed to be made of a smooth material, almost like jade, and there was a pond in the middle of the room.

Xiao Hua didn’t say anything and approached the pond in the center of the room before sitting beside it and staring at it.

Feng Yuxiang also did the same thing.

“Come. We’ll be able to see the Young Master here.”

Everyone there sat around this pond a moment later, silently staring at the clear liquid.

A few minutes later, they could see an image appearing on the surface of the water.

“Look! It’s Yuan!” Chu Liuxiang exclaimed when she realized it was Yuan, and he just entered this arena.

“Looks like he’s about to start his first trial.” Feng Yuxiang smiled.

Meanwhile, somewhere in the Stairway to Heaven, Yuan was waiting for his first trial to begin.

After waiting around for a few moments, he noticed the scenery changing from the void to a bustling city where people could be seen walking around.

The scenery looked so realistic to Yuan that he thought he’d been transported to a real city.

“For the first trial, you must find the city lord and kill him within 12 hours or you will fail the trial.” Tian’er’s voice resounded loudly in Yuan’s ears, but the people there didn’t react to her voice.

“Wait... You want me to kill someone?” Yuan frowned at this trial.

“Don’t worry, everyone and everything in this world is created purely from spiritual energy, just like Tian’er, so they’re not real.”

Yuan felt more relieved after hearing that.

“What about the rules? Are there any rules?” He then asked.

“There are no rules in this trial. You may accomplish your mission through any means.”

“I understand.”

“Then the trial shall begin.”

Ding!

[You have started your first trial in the Stairway to Heaven]

[You have 12 hours to finish the trial]

[Finish the trial in less than 6 hours to receive a reward]

‘Huh? I can obtain rewards in the Stairway to Heaven?’ Yuan wasn’t expecting to earn anything since he was doing it to ascend to the next realm, not earn treasures.

However, he didn’t complain about it and began his journey.

The first and most logical thing he did was to ask around for information.

“Excuse me, I am new here, and I have some business with the lord of this city. Can you tell me where I can find him?” Yuan asked an old lady who was the closest to him.

The old lady stared at him for a moment before pointing in a certain direction.

Yuan turned to look at where the old lady was pointing, and to his surprise, there was a majestic pagoda in that direction.

The pagoda was so tall that it pierced the clouds; it was unlike anything Yuan has seen before.

“Thank you.”

Yuan immediately made his way towards the pagoda.

However, not even a few minutes later, a sudden commotion occurred in the street, and it forced him to stop his movements.

“You bastard! How dare you sleep with my wife! I am going to fucking kill you!”

A strange man that he'd never seen before suddenly appeared in front of him and began threatening to kill him.

“What gibberish are you talking about? I didn't—” Yuan frowned.

However, the strange man didn't care about what Yuan had to say and drew his weapon.

“Die for me!”

The strange man released his cultivation base and began running at Yuan.

‘A peak Spirit Grandmaster?!’ Yuan immediately withdrew the Empyrean Overlord to defend against this strange man.

Bang!

Yuan could feel himself getting pushed back a few steps from the confrontation.

“W-Wait a moment! There must have been a misunderstanding! I didn't sleep with your wife!” Yuan tried to calm the man down, but alas, his attempt only seemed to have intensified the man's anger.

“Fuck you! I was there when it happened and saw you lying naked in bed with my wife! Die!”

The strange man continued his assault on Yuan.

‘This must be part of the trial! I thought I only had to fight the city lord! I underestimated the trial!’ Yuan eventually realized the situation and began fighting the man for real.

After exchanging a few blows, Yuan withdrew the Starry Abyss in its invisible form and used it to finish off the unsuspecting man.

The strange man collapsed after a hole appeared in his head, and the pedestrians there began freaking out as though they were real people.

Yuan ignored them and continued making his way towards the pagoda.

After Yuan left the scene, the strange man's corpse scattered into countless glowing fragments before disappearing like smoke.

A few minutes later, even more people showed up to block his path.

“Halt, you murderer!”

Two people wearing guard uniforms showed up.

Yuan didn't even bother to stop this time and just used the Starry Abyss to kill them before they realized what was happening.

This continued for an entire hour until Yuan finally reached the pagoda, and by then, he'd killed over 50 people at the peak Spirit Grandmaster realm.

Yuan stood before the pagoda's golden doors, but he didn't immediately go inside.

Instead, he sat down to recover his spiritual energy.

‘It's already this bothersome when it's only the first trial. I cannot imagine what the Stairway to Heaven has in store for me later...’ He sighed inwardly.

Chapter 666: Vanishing Ghost's Soundless Blade

After spending an hour recovering his spiritual energy, Yuan was prepared to enter the pagoda that had over a hundred floors.

‘Will I be able to reach the peak and defeat the city lord in less than three hours?’ He wondered to himself as he opened the door and entered the pagoda.

Inside of the pagoda wasn’t as big as Yuan expected, but there was more than enough space for two cultivators to fight without restrictions.

Yuan looked around the first floor that appeared to be a dojo, and it reminded him of another place he’d challenged before—the Carp Leaping Over Dragon’s Gate Tower within the Dragon Essence Temple.

However, instead of fighting magical beasts, humans were his opponents this time.

“Who are you? And what are you doing in my lord’s pagoda?” A figure suddenly appeared before Yuan without him noticing until this person spoke.

Yuan looked at the middle-aged man and said, “I am here to speak with your lord.”

“Do you have an appointment?” The middle-aged man asked.

“I do not.”

“Then you may scram out of here.”

“Unfortunately, that’s not possible either.”

“Is that so?”

The middle-aged man retrieved his weapon that was a spear the next moment and pointed it at Yuan.

“Then you can stay here forever.”

Yuan didn’t say anything and retrieved the Empyrean Overlord.

“Scram!”

The middle-aged man rushed at Yuan, releasing his first level Spirit Lord cultivation base.

Yuan decided to pretend to struggle against him until the time was right.

A dozen exchanges later, Yuan retrieved the Starry Abyss and aimed it directly at the middle-aged man’s head before sending it flying towards it.

However, the middle-aged man tilted his head when the dagger was an inch away from his face, narrowly dodging the sneak attack.

‘What?!’ Yuan was shocked when the middle-aged man dodged his Starry Abyss.

This is his first time missing his target, and he even doubted whether the Starry Abyss was actually invisible or not.

“Hmph! Using such cowardly tactics! Your invisible attack might work on weaker opponents, but it’s useless before me!”

Yuan frowned when he realized it wasn’t by chance that the middle-aged man had dodged his invisible dagger.

‘Does he have a technique that allows him to detect invisible objects?’ He wondered inwardly.

However, even if his opponent can detect the Starry Abyss, he could still use it as a distraction.

“Enough standing around! Let’s finish this!”

The middle-aged man continued to attack Yuan the next moment.

[Heavenly Domain!]

Yuan decided to use Heavenly Domain to restrict his movements.

“What the heck is this?!”

Although the man was surprised, it was not enough to completely seal his movements, but that was to be expected, as he was a genuine Spirit Lord.

When the man was taken by surprise, Yuan used this chance to go for the killing blow.

“Bloody—”

However, Yuan stopped his technique midway when he realized something.

‘Even though this technique has served me well, and it is also one of the first techniques that I’ve learned in this world, I should stop using this technique that belongs to the Blood Sect.’

There were many reasons as to why Yuan no longer wanted to use the Bloody Sword Strike any longer, but the most obvious reason was its affiliation with the Blood Sect, and he didn’t want to be mistaken as someone from the Blood Sect like previously.

Unfortunately, besides the Bloody Sword Strike, he didn’t really have any other techniques that weren’t over-the-top like the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike and the Relentless Dragon Overwhelms the Nine Heavens.

As for the Demon Sealing Strike... It most likely wouldn’t work on humans.

‘Although I have never used that technique before, I have seen it used many times in my dreams... Let’s see if I can pull it off...’

After exchanging a few more strikes with the man, Yuan distanced himself until he was all the way at the doors.

“Now you feel like leaving? Too bad. You lost that chance when you withdrew your sword.” The man sneered in disdain when he saw Yuan running away.

Yuan ignored the man’s provoking words and focused on the technique inside his head.

Once he was confident that he could execute it, he took a deep breath and changed the way he held the sword.

The man raised his eyebrows at Yuan’s weird stance that made it look like he was about to sprint with the sword by his waist.

“I don’t know what you’re thinking, but if you think you can defeat me while being a whole realm below me, you’re too arrogant. Allow me to show you the difference between heaven and earth.”

However, right as the man finished his sentence, he suddenly felt a cold chill going down his spine.

The man was in disbelief.

‘T-This feeling is... fear?! Impossible! Why would I fear a mere Spirit Grandmaster?!’ He cried inwardly.

It was at this moment Yuan finished his preparations and launched his attack.

“Vanishing Ghost’s Soundless Blade...”

The Empyrean Overlord in Yuan’s hand disappeared for a split second in the man’s eyes even though he had been staring at it this entire time without blinking. There was no movement, no sound— nothing.

“Hah! What the heck? How dare you try to scare—”

The man suddenly stopped speaking when he felt something off about his neck, but before he could figure out what was wrong with it, the light in his eyes darkened, and his body collapsed the next second.

The second his body hit the floor, his head that had been cleanly severed began rolling like a bowling ball.

Yuan released a sigh of relief after seeing that he'd successfully managed to execute the technique properly.

Ding!

[You have learned Vanishing Ghost's Soundless Blade]

[Vanishing Ghost's Soundless Blade]

[Rank: Ancient]

[Mastery Level: 1]

[Description: An extremely fast and deadly technique that can kill a thousand people without making the slightest sound. Created by the famous Cultivator known as Vanishing Ghost, who was once regarded as the Nine Heaven's deadliest assassin.]

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Chapter 667: Fighting the City Lord

After killing the man, Yuan proceeded to the next floor.

‘His sword technique is really powerful... And it doesn’t consume as much spiritual energy as the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike.’ Yuan thought to himself as he climbed the staircase.

Upon reaching the second floor, Yuan encountered another man with the cultivation of a Spirit Lord.

“Who are you? What happened to the guard downstairs?” The man asked him with an unfriendly look.

Yuan didn’t bother responding to the man and withdrew his sword, as he was already expecting to fight anyone that gets in his way.

“Hmph. A mere Spirit Grandmaster.” The man didn’t say anything else and withdrew his weapon.

Their weapons collided a moment later.

Yuan decided to try using the Starry Abyss again just to make sure it still works.

However, just like the man downstairs, this one could also somehow track his invisible flying dagger.

‘Just how are they tracking my Starry Abyss? It’s invisible, and its presence should be concealed. How else can they track it?’

A few minutes later, Yuan managed to defeat the man without using the soundless blade technique.

And for the next hour, he would repeat the same thing.

However, his streak was stopped by an unexpected situation.

When he arrived on the ninth floor, the guard there didn't attack him.

"The Lord wishes to meet you. You may go up."

Yuan was skeptical at first, thinking that it was a trap, but the guard really allowed him to go upstairs without causing any trouble.

Now without anyone blocking his path, Yuan managed to climb to the highest floor in less than ten minutes.

Upon reaching the top floor, Yuan could see a figure sitting in the back of the room, and this person was wearing a black mask.

"Are you the city lord?" Yuan asked him for confirmation.

"Indeed." He nodded.

And he continued, "Now that I have answered your question, allow me to ask you one of mine."

"Who are you and why are you killing my people who have done no wrong?"

Yuan's body trembled slightly after hearing such words.

'Calm down... They are not real people. This is simply a trial by the Stairway to Heaven...'

He quickly calmed himself down.

"Because I have no other choice," he responded a moment later.

“That’s nonsense and you know it!” The City Lord shouted in an angry voice.

“Enough talking and let’s get this over with.” Yuan pointed the Empyrean Overlord at him.

“Very well. If you wish to die, allow me to end your miserable life for you.”

The City Lord released his cultivation base, which shocked Yuan.

‘This feeling is... He’s a Spirit King?!?!’ He cried inwardly after recognizing this overbearing aura.

Does the Stairway to Heaven really intend on making him fight someone two whole realms above him?

Why is it this difficult to ascend to the next realm?

Even if he’s helping four other people, it shouldn’t be this hard!

“Are you scared?” The City Lord suddenly said as he approached Yuan.

“I can sense your fear crawling all over my skin.”

Yuan tightened his grasp on his sword and patiently waited for the City Lord to attack him first.

“Why are you just standing there? Come and attack me like you did to those guards you killed not long ago.”

Although Yuan couldn’t see the City Lord’s face, he had a good feeling that there was a grin behind that mask at this moment.

“If you’re not going to attack me first, I won’t be humble!”

The City Lord used a movement skill to instantly close their distance.

“?!”

Yuan quickly reacted by lifting his sword in front of his face.

Clang!

Bang!

Although he'd blocked the attack, his body was still sent flying by the overwhelming power from the strike.

After hitting the wall with his back, Yuan tried to rebalance himself, but before he could even stand still, the City Lord had arrived in front of him again.

The City Lord then gave Yuan a good kick in his side, sending him flying for a second time in just a few seconds.

“What’s the matter? You’re a lot weaker than I’d anticipated. If I didn’t let you through, you would’ve probably fallen to one of my guards sooner or later, and you would’ve never made it up here.”

This time, the City Lord allowed Yuan to get back onto his feet.

Ding!

The City Lord suddenly lifted his sword and placed it right behind his head, and the sound of metal colliding resounded half a second later.

“An invisible dagger? You really think such pathetic tricks would work on Cultivators at my level? Although it’s invisible and it hides its presence pretty decently, those at Spirit Lord and above can easily see it with their enhanced divine sense. You’re wasting your time using this kind of tactic on us.”

‘So that’s why everyone I have fought in this pagoda could track my invisible flying dagger perfectly... Their divine sense is powerful enough to bypass the Starry Abyss’ ability...’ Yuan sighed inwardly.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan spoke with a frown on his face, “Can you shut up for a minute? The way you talk reminds me of a certain someone,

and it's ruining the mood for me."

"Oh? Now that's interesting. Who do I remind you of?" The City Lord became interested for some reason.

"That's none of your business."

"Maybe it is. You never know."

The City Lord then moved his hand to remove the mask covering his face, revealing to Yuan a very familiar face.

"Y-You are—!"

Yuan was shocked when he saw the City Lord's face that looked exactly like the handsome man in his dream.

The only reason he didn't realize it until now was simply because the City Lord had changed his voice to something unrecognizable.

"Since you're here, it must mean that another reincarnation has occurred. How many times have you reincarnated by now? Have you achieved the goal yet?" The handsome man asked him with a profound smile.

Chapter 668: Frustration

After snapping out of his daze from the handsome man's question, Yuan laughed a little before speaking, "What a coincidence. I also have a similar question. What the heck is up with all of this reincarnation stuff?"

"Tell me everything you know about it! How else am I supposed to achieve this goal you speak of when I don't even remember it?!"

The handsome man silently stared at Yuan for a good moment.

"I see... So you don't remember anything yet. That's fine. It's not the first time that you have forgotten about your past, but you will eventually remember everything."

"However, don't expect me to spoon feed you everything just because we belong to the same soul. If you want to remember your memories, you will have to defeat me. Why else would I force myself to do the trials in this place?"

"Good! I have always wanted to give you a good beating but never got the chance since you're always much stronger than me in my dreams!" Yuan said.

The two of them continued fighting again shortly after.

Meanwhile, in the spectators' room.

"What happened?! Why did it stop working?!" Chu Liuxiang exclaimed when the water suddenly stopped reflecting Yuan and the City Lord right when the City Lord was about to remove his mask.

Unfortunately, nobody there could answer her question.

“I don’t know what happened, but we can only wait until it returns.” Feng Yuxiang said.

Back in the pagoda, Yuan and the handsome man fought each other so viciously that they’d collapsed some of the floors there.

“Hmmm... You’re still lacking. When I was at your level, Spirit Kings were no match for me. However, that shouldn’t be possible. You should be far stronger than me since you’re reincarnated.” The handsome man spoke as he fought.

After pondering for a moment, he continued, “Perhaps you didn’t fully awaken your bloodline? Or maybe you don’t know how to use it? You don’t know anything, do you?”

Yuan frowned when he heard this, and he said, “Why would I know? I don’t know about the reincarnation. I don’t know about my past. I don’t even know my purpose. And you expect me to know about my bloodline? You’re right— I don’t know anything!”

Yuan felt frustrated that he knew nothing about himself even though there’s clearly a lot he should be aware about.

The handsome man smiled when he noticed Yuan’s attack getting fiercer and more powerful due to his frustration.

“Sometimes it’s better to not know anything, because once you learn everything, you will not be the same person.”

“I will decide what kind of person I will become no matter what happened in the past!” Yuan shouted.

“You’re not the first one to say such words, and these people all ended up changing after they recalled their past and purpose.” The handsome man chuckled.

“You’re confused because you don’t know anything. However, once you remember everything, you will understand.”

“You don’t know that!”

Clang!

Yuan swung the Empyrean Overlord with all of his strength.

However, the handsome man blocked it with ease.

“I do— because we are the same person.” He smiled.

“You see, we’re not like the others. When others go through the cycle of reincarnation, they will lose their memories and live a new life with a new identity— they will become someone unrecognizable and walk a unique path that’s different from their past self.”

“However, we’re not like that. Although we sometimes lose our memories and take on a new identity, we will eventually return to our original identity and walk the same path we once walked. This is our destiny— our heavenly fate that I— you started.”

“Heavenly Domain!”

Yuan suddenly released the Heavenly Domain, slowing down the handsome man’s movements.

He then activated Dragon’s Gaze, freezing his movement for a brief moment.

“Heaven Splitting Sword Strike!”

Yuan used this brief moment to gather as much spiritual energy as he could before releasing it, and thanks to his Empyrean Overlord that recently upgraded its unique ability, the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike was more powerful than ever.

BOOM!

The golden light enveloped the handsome man’s figure before blowing a massive hole in the pagoda.

However, once the golden light disappeared, the handsome man was still standing in the same spot, and he didn't even have a single scratch on his body.

"I-Impossible..." Yuan was left speechless by the results.

The handsome man had eaten his Heaven Splitting Sword Strike head-on and managed to remain unscathed? How is he supposed to defeat such a monster?

"Hahaha!"

The handsome man suddenly burst out laughing.

"You should see the expression on your face right now! You look like someone who just saw a ghost!"

After laughing for a bit, the handsome man looked at Yuan with a calm smile on his face and said, "Don't worry, you have already passed this trial."

"W-What?" Yuan's eyes widened at his words.

"Although I may look unharmed, I had actually died in that attack just now. I merely reconstructed myself. After all, I am made out of spiritual energy."

And sure enough, a notification that announced the end of his trial appeared the next moment.

[You have killed the City Lord and successfully cleared the first trial]

[You have cleared the trial in less than 6 hours]

"Here's your reward." The handsome man suddenly extended his hand that was holding a glowing orb of light.

"What's that?"

"You were just asking for it not long ago."

“Y-You don’t mean...”

“That’s right. It’s your memories— your answer. However, it’s only a small fragment of it. If you want the rest, you’ll have to continue challenging the Stairway to Heaven.”

Yuan sighed, “Why are you making things difficult for me— for yourself?”

The handsome man smiled and said, “This is for your own good. And it’s not just you. Everyone that came here before you had to go through the same thing.”

Yuan silently stared at the orb floating above the handsome man’s hand.

“Here. Take it.”

The handsome man suddenly flicked his finger, sending the orb of light straight into Yuan’s forehead, and Yuan’s vision blackened the next moment.

Chapter 669: Tian Yang's Memories

‘Ugh... Where am I...?’ Yuan slowly opened his eyes to the sound of water splashing beside him.

He looked around once his eyes adjusted to the bright sunlight, and to his surprise, there was a large river beside him.

‘What the... How did I get here? I was just at the pagoda...’

Yuan stood up a moment later, but he immediately noticed something different about his body.

“My cultivation base is gone!” He exclaimed in a shocked voice.

Suddenly, another voice resounded, responding to his words, “Are you still dreaming, Tian Yang? You’re not even a cultivator yet, how can you possibly have a cultivation base?”

“Eh?”

Yuan turned to the sound of the voice to see a pretty young girl sitting underneath a tree with a scroll in her hands.

“Meng Lili?” Yuan subconsciously muttered her name even though he had never met her before.

‘Wait... Did she just call me Tian Yang? So I am seeing his memories right now?’

Now that he had an idea of his situation, Yuan decided to play along.

However, it was not as though he could actually control his body freely.

Yuan suddenly began walking towards this young lady named Meng Lili.

“How are you feeling, Meng Lili? Are you excited about tomorrow? Nervous?” Yuan asked her.

“Neither. I am actually feeling afraid,” she responded.

“Why would you feel afraid? We’re going to become disciples of a cultivation sect! You should be excited!”

“Tian Yang, the cultivation world isn’t all fun and games. It’s a vicious path that could easily lead to your death even when you’re not at fault, and it’s a world that we’ll be stepping into soon.”

“If you’re afraid, then why did you agree to join the sect? You could have stayed here in the village with the others.”

“Although I am afraid of the cultivation world, there is something I am even more afraid of—the feeling of being powerless,” she responded with a solemn look on her face.

“...”

Yuan didn’t say anything else for the next few moments.

“Enough about me. What about you? You’ve always wanted to be a Cultivator, right?” Meng Lili suddenly asked him.

A bittersweet smile appeared on Yuan’s face as he spoke, “No, not always. I never even thought about becoming a Cultivator until my mother and sister died at the hands of one.”

“Oh... I am sorry for bringing it up...” Meng Lili said in a dispirited voice.

“There’s no need for you to apologize. It’s the person who killed them that should apologize. Once I become a Cultivator, I will find this bastard and kill him myself if he’s still alive by then.”

“Cultivators are not allowed to kill mortals, so that person must have already been executed by now.” Meng Lili said.

“If that’s the case, he’s really fortunate.” Yuan sneered.

“Anyways, I am going back to the village. I’ll see you tomorrow when the Senior picks us up.”

After leaving the scene, Yuan walked about a mile until he arrived in this small village that had a population of a few thousand residents.

“I’m home.” Yuan said out loud after returning to his residence, but there was no response.

He then walked to the living room, where a home altar for his family was built in the corner of the room.

He kneeled in front of it and stared at the altar for many minutes before speaking in a solemn voice, “I will be leaving this place tomorrow to start my journey as a Cultivator. I know the world of cultivation is a dangerous one with countless victims. However, I rather risk my life to have a chance of becoming someone powerful than doing nothing and becoming a victim to the powerful.”

“Meng Lili said something that really resonated with me today, and I completely agree with her. She said that she fears being powerless more than she fears death. However, while I do fear being powerless, I don’t fear death. If I die, I will just reunite with the rest of you, so I look forward to that.”

“If I don’t die and become powerful enough, I... I’m not sure what I want to do at that time yet, but I hope to find the answer soon.”

Once he finished praying, Yuan went to tend the chickens he raised in his backyard.

“After today, you’ll be Uncle Lee’s chickens. It’s unfortunate that I have to give you away before I can eat you, but alas, cultivation is more important,

and the sect does not allow animals.”

After feeding the chickens, Yuan went inside his room and proceeded to spend the rest of the day meditating.

The following morning, Yuan left his house and went to the entrance of the village, where a group of people around his age were gathered.

“Did you sleep well?” Meng Lili approached him shortly after he arrived.

“I spent the whole night meditating,” he said.

“What’s the point of that when you’re not even a Cultivator?”

“To prepare myself for the real thing, of course.”

“Whatever.”

About an hour later, an old man with an unfathomable aura descended from the sky and landed in front of the group.

He withdrew his flying treasure that took the shape of a massive leaf and said, “This is your last chance to turn back. Once you step on this flying treasure, you will either spend the rest of your life as a Cultivator or die as a mortal in the sect. I will give you all 30 seconds to decide.”

30 seconds later, everyone was standing on the flying treasure.

“Good.”

The old man flew away with the flying treasure a moment later.

It was also at this moment that Yuan returned to the pagoda, and the first thing he noticed was the handsome man standing in front of him with a profound smile.

“What do you think?” The handsome man asked him.

Yuan frowned and said, “That’s it? I didn’t even learn anything about my reincarnation or bloodline!”

The handsome man chuckled and said, “Like I’d said, you’ll only get a fragment of your memories. And don’t worry, I gave you a lot more memories than what you just saw, but it’ll take time for them to surface. Give it a few days.”

“In the meantime, you can continue climbing the Stairway to Heaven to regain even more of your memories. You still have a few more trials ahead of you, after all.”

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Chapter 670: Stairway to Heaven's Second Trial

“Don’t screw with me! You’re just wasting time! Why can’t you tell me what really matters? I don’t care about the other memories!” Yuan frowned at the handsome man’s words.

“Now that wouldn’t be fun at all, would it? Furthermore, who tells a story that starts from the middle— the most exciting part? That makes no sense and will only take away the excitement.” The handsome man casually shrugged.

“Anyways, I won’t keep you here any longer. Have fun with the rest of the trial.”

The handsome man disappeared the next moment, and the scenery began to disappear shortly after.

In just a few breaths of time, Yuan returned back to the arena with a starry background.

“Congratulations on passing your first trial, Master.” Tian’er’s voice resounded.

Yuan looked up into the darkness and asked, “How many more trials do I need to complete before I arrive at the next realm?”

“...”

After a moment of silence, Tian’er said, “I cannot answer that question, Master, as it’s different for everyone. Some require four trials while some only require one trial to ascend.”

“What? How is that even fair? And how are the trials decided?”

“They are decided by the participants’ talent, destiny, and if they are helping others ascend. The more talented you are, the more difficult the trials will become.”

“Destiny? You’re telling me that the Stairway to Heaven can tell someone’s destiny?”

“That is correct.”

“Then can you tell me my destiny?”

“That is not how this works, Master.”

“Whatever. Let me continue my trial then.”

“You are allowed an hour to recover your spiritual energy after every trial. If you wish to advance without resting, just say so.”

Yuan nodded and said, “I will need every ounce of spiritual energy I can get.”

He sat down the next moment and began recovering his spiritual energy.

‘Wow! I should’ve noticed this sooner! The spiritual energy in this place is so pure! I can feel my cultivation base soaring towards the next level as it recovers!’ Yuan was shocked when he absorbed the spiritual energy in the Stairway to Heaven.

And sure enough, right before his one hour was up, he’d managed to breakthrough to the next level, reaching the fifth level of Spirit Grandmaster.

“Congratulations on your breakthrough, Master.” Tian’er said to him.

“Thank you. I am ready for the next trial.” Yuan then said.

“Please climb that staircase for your next trial.”

Yuan looked around until he saw the staircase Tian'er was talking about, and he began climbing it shortly after.

Meanwhile, in the spectators' room.

"It's back!" Min Li exclaimed in an excited voice when the pond started working again.

"Hm? What happened? Why did he return to that place? What happened to the trial? Did he pass or fail?" Chu Liuxiang asked.

"Seeing that he's climbing the staircase, he most likely passed the first trial and is heading to his second one." Feng Yuxiang said.

Sometime later, Yuan arrived at the second arena.

"The second trial will now begin." Tian'er's calm voice resounded.

The scenery changed a few moments later.

Yuan looked around to find himself at some kind of dock with many large wooden ships stationed there.

"What's my trial this time?" Yuan asked.

"For the second trial, you must escort the Huang Family 100,000 miles until they reach the Giant's Continent. Your trial will fail if anyone from the Huang Family dies."

"100,000 miles?! How long will that take?!" Yuan exclaimed out loud when he heard the distance he had to travel.

"The ships are quite fast, so it shouldn't take too long." Tian'er responded.

"Even if they move 1,000 miles an hour, it would still take 100 hours to complete the trial!" Yuan sighed out loud.

"I have no control over what trial the Master undergoes," she calmly responded.

Ding!

[You have started your second trial in the Stairway to Heaven!]

[You must escort the Huang Family 100,000 miles until they reach the Giant's Continent with all of them alive to finish the trial]

[Finish the trial with all of the Huang Family's bodyguards alive to receive a reward]

Yuan released a deep sigh before looking around the dock for the Huang Family.

"Excuse me, do you know of the Huang Family?" Yuan asked the people there.

However, it took a couple of tries this time since not everybody knew of this Huang Family.

"Oh, the Huang Family? You can find them at the Silver Peak Restaurant. They are currently recruiting bodyguards."

"Can you tell me which direction is this restaurant?"

Once he received the directions, Yuan thanked the man before making his way towards this restaurant.

He arrived at his destination about ten minutes later, and sure enough, there was a large carriage stationed in front of the restaurant with a sign that read 'Hiring bodyguards! 10,000,000 gold coins with bonuses! Must be at least Spirit Lord!'.

'I'm only a Spirit Grandmaster, but I can defeat a Spirit Lord... Hopefully, they won't mind it...'

There was already a long line of people waiting to be recruited, so Yuan entered the line and began waiting, silently observing the situation there while he waited.

“If you want to become a bodyguard, you must prove to me that you can protect my family! This man beside me is a peak Spirit Lord, and he will be testing your capabilities! Whether you can become a bodyguard or not will be at his discretion!” A middle-aged man with sharp facial features said to the crowd of people there.

‘He must be the head of the Huang Family...’ Yuan thought to himself.

A few moments later, someone from the front of the line approached the peak Spirit Lord bodyguard.

“You have three chances. Give me your best strike.” The peak Spirit Lord said to the recruit.

The recruit nodded, and without hesitation, attacked the peak Spirit Lord with his strongest attack that was backed by the power of a fourth level Spirit Lord.

However, the peak Spirit Lord didn’t even bother moving, almost like he had no intention of blocking it.

Bang!

The attack landed on the peak Spirit Lord the next second, but to everybody’s surprise, he came out unscathed by the attack.

“He’s an Array Master!” Someone there exclaimed after realizing what had blocked the attack.

Chapter 671: Bodyguard

‘An Array Master? Feng Feng mentioned them not long ago...’ Yuan looked at the peak Spirit Lord with an interested gaze.

Although it was faint, he could see a semi-transparent barrier around the peak Spirit Lord, and if he looked at the barrier with his divine sense, he would be able to see the symbols that supported the barrier together.

‘Those symbols contain most of the spiritual energy... Is that the barrier’s true form? A bunch of symbols combined together?’ He thought to himself.

“You have two more attacks. If you can crack my array, I will consider you hired.” The peak Spirit Lord said to the recruit.

However, even after using his last two chances, the recruit had failed to make even the slightest crack on the barrier.

“Next!” The middle-aged man said.

The next recruit stepped forward and tried to crack the array created by the peak Spirit Lord but to no avail.

After going through five people without any success, they finally managed to find someone who could crack the array on his third strike, but the crack was very miniscule and less than an inch long.

The peak Spirit Lord silently stared at the crack for a moment before speaking, “Fail!”

“What?! But I managed to crack your array!” The recruit exclaimed, unwilling to accept the results.

“So what if you barely managed to crack it? It’s still not convincing enough. If you want to blame someone, blame yourself for being weak.”

Meanwhile, a small commotion broke out somewhere in the line.

“Hey! Can’t you read? Only Spirit Lords and above can qualify to be their bodyguard! You, who is a mere Spirit Grandmaster, should get out of the line and stop wasting our time! Hell, you’re not even a peak Spirit Grandmaster!”

Upon hearing these words that were spoken right behind him, Yuan turned around, and sure enough, there was someone with a displeased face staring at him.

“So what if I am not a Spirit Lord? I can handle Spirit Lords like you any time of the day.” Yuan was feeling annoyed that he was being bothered even though he had been minding his own business.

“What did you just say, you little bastard?!” The man immediately fumed with anger.

“How dare a little Spirit Grandmaster like you act so arrogantly before me?! Know your place!”

The man released his cultivation base that was at the 8th level Spirit Lord.

He then raised his fist and prepared to strike Yuan.

However, he was a second too late, as Yuan’s fists were already in motion.

“Relentless Dragon Overwhelms the Nine Heavens!”

Yuan used his fist technique for the first time in combat on an opponent after obtaining it from the Dragon Temple.

Since these people are not actually living and are only made out of spiritual energy, Yuan did not bother holding back and was acting even a little daring.

BOOM!

The man was sent flying into the distance like a rag doll until he crashed into a building a street away and collapsed on the floor.

However, the man did not stand back up even many moments later, as he'd died on impact by Yuan's ancient-rank skill.

"Hmph."

Yuan didn't even bother to check the man's condition and treated the whole situation as though he was getting rid of an annoying insect.

The people that witnessed their quick exchange that ended in the blink of an eye were shocked speechless.

They couldn't believe their eyes— did a Spirit Grandmaster just defeat a Spirit Lord, someone an entire realm above his own cultivation?

Why would this kind of genius be willing to become a bodyguard for someone else?

"What's with the commotion back there?!" The peak Spirit Lord left his position and approached Yuan due to their little fight.

"Who was just fighting back here?!" He asked them, as he didn't witness the fight for himself.

Those who saw the fight immediately pointed at Yuan with their fingers.

The peak Spirit Lord frowned when he saw Yuan's cultivation base.

"Why are you even in line? The sign states very clearly that only Spirit Lords and above will be accepted! And the last time I checked, Spirit Grandmaster is not above Spirit Lord!"

Yuan looked at him in the eyes and responded in a calm voice, "While my cultivation isn't at the level of a Spirit Lord, I am not any weaker than one."

The peak Spirit Lord narrowed his eyes at Yuan.

He then said, “I will be the judge of that. Hit me with all you’ve got.”

Yuan nodded and withdrew his Empyrean Overlord.

‘A Soul Weapon... This guy is not an ordinary one...’

The middle-aged man standing beside the carriage immediately recognized the Empyrean Overlord’s unique aura to be a Soul Weapon.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan began gathering as much spiritual energy as he could for the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike.

“T-This is...”

The peak Spirit Lord began sweating profusely when he realized just how much spiritual energy Yuan was gathering in his sword.

He knew very well that even if he was a Spirit King, neither he nor his array would be able to survive such a powerful attack.

“W-W-Wait a moment!” The peak Spirit Lord suddenly stopped him.

“You don’t need to continue. I am convinced by your strength.”

“Eh? Really? Does this mean you’ll recruit me as a bodyguard?” Yuan was pleasantly surprised.

“Y-Yes... That’s right. You can become a bodyguard for the Huang Family.” The peak Spirit Lord nodded with a somewhat flushed face, feeling a little heat on his cheeks, almost like someone had slapped it.

“I understand.” Yuan stowed away the Empyrean Overlord the next moment.

“My name is Dong Zhou, head of security for the Huang Family. What is your name?” The peak Spirit Lord clasped his hand and bowed in a respectful manner.

“You can call me Yuan.”

“Then, Yuan, you can wait inside the restaurant for now. We’re going to recruit a couple more bodyguards before we leave. You can order whatever you want in the meantime. The Huang Family will pay for everything,” said Dong Zhou.

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Chapter 672: Giant's Continent

Yuan proceeded to make his way into the restaurant after being accepted as a bodyguard for the Huang Family.

“Please wait a second, Yuan.”

A soothing voice suddenly called out to him just as he was able to enter the restaurant.

He halted his movements and turned around to see a pretty young lady walking out of the carriage.

Yuan's eyes widened with surprise when he saw this young lady.

“Lulu? What are you doing here?” Yuan subconsciously blurted out loud, as this young lady greatly resembled Chu Liuxiang.

From her brown hair to hazel eyes, it was almost as though Chu Liuxiang herself was there.

However, after closer inspection, although very minor, there were some differences.

“Lulu?” The young lady raised her eyebrows.

“S-Sorry, I mistook you for someone else. You look very similar to one of my friends,” he corrected himself.

The young lady chuckled at his words and said, “My name is Huang Xiao Li. If you don't mind, may I accompany you in the restaurant? I'm feeling a little hungry, too.”

“Uhh...”

Yuan looked at the middle-aged man standing beside Huang Xiao Li.

“Entertaining my family is also part of your job as a bodyguard,” he said.

Yuan nodded.

“You can just call me Xiao Li,” she said as she followed him into the restaurant.

Meanwhile, in the spectators’ area.

“W-Why does she look exactly like me?!” Chu Liuxiang exclaimed in a voice filled with disbelief when she saw Huang Xiao Li’s face.

It felt like she was looking in the mirror when she looked at Huang Xiao Li.

“Maybe the Stairway to Heaven is using our faces for whatever reason.” Feng Yuxiang said.

“And it decided to use my face? I hope she doesn’t do anything weird...” Chu Liuxiang sighed.

Once they were inside the restaurant, Yuan and Huang Xiao Li sat down at a small round table.

“Go ahead and order whatever you like. I will pay for it.” Huang Xiao Li said to him.

The server arrived at their table a few moments later to take their order.

“I will have this... this... this... and this... oh, this as well...”

Yuan stared at Huang Xiao Li with wide eyes as she ordered over a dozen dishes without hesitation.

Normally, he would be the one to surprise the others with his big appetite, but Huang Xiao Li had beat him to the punch this time.

“Okay, your turn, Yuan.” Huang Xiao Li said to him after she finished.

He nodded and began ordering a long list of dishes, dumbfounding Huang Xiao Li.

The server taking their orders cried inwardly, ‘Are you two competing to see who can eat more or what?’

“Esteemed guests, let’s move to a bigger table... This place won’t be able to hold all of your food...” The server said to them afterward.

They agreed and moved to a private room that had a much larger table.

“Now then... While we wait for our food, why don’t you tell me a little about yourself, Yuan? Why did you want to be a bodyguard for my family? You seem like a very talented young man. I cannot imagine someone like you willingly becoming a bodyguard for others. There must be some kind of catch.”

Yuan smiled, “You’re right. I am actually trying to travel to the Giant’s Continent, but I don’t have any money. Fortunately for me, I get to travel there and obtain some money because of your Huang Family.”

Huang Xiao Li narrowed her eyes at him for a moment before relaxing herself.

“Well, I don’t really care why you’re helping us as long as you protect my family and I.”

“I will try my best to make sure that no harm will come to your family.” Yuan nodded.

The food began arriving a few minutes later, and the two of them began cleaning their plates at a fast pace, almost like they were in a race to beat the other.

“You’re pretty good.” Huang Xiao Li said to him after they finished eating.

“Do you always eat this much?”

“Only when I can...” He said.

“Why don’t you tell me a little about yourself, Yuan. I like to know about those working for us. Do you belong to a cultivation sect?”

“I used to, but I am no longer affiliated with them. I am currently a rogue Cultivator,” he said.

“Hoh? Why did you leave? Disciples don’t normally leave their sect. Perhaps you were forced out?”

“No, nothing of that sort. I left simply because I wanted to explore the world by myself.”

“I see... That’s a respectable decision.”

“What about you? Why are you— your family heading to the Giant’s Continent?”

Huang Xiao Li raised her eyebrows at his question before speaking, “There’s only one reason why people go to the Giant’s Continent— to trade treasures with the Giants living there, of course! Aren’t you also going there to trade treasures? Why else would you go there?”

“G-Giants...? You mean there are real giants living there?” Yuan was speechless.

“You didn’t know that...? And you’re trying to go there?” Huang Xiao Li looked at him with a suspicious gaze.

Yuan quickly said, “Actually, it was a friend who told me about the Giant’s Continent, but he never mentioned anything about giants. He also told me to go there if I want to acquire rare treasures, but that’s all. I guess he wanted to keep it a surprise.”

“Is that so... Anyways, that’s why we’re going there— to exchange treasures. However, in order to do so, we must also have a lot of treasures, hence why we’re recruiting bodyguards, just in case someone decides to

steal from us. It's also quite dangerous going there, so we'll need all the help we can get."

A few minutes later, Huang Xiao Li's father came to get them.

"We just finished recruiting our bodyguards. We'll be leaving now."

"Okay." Huang Xiao Li nodded.

"See you later, Yuan."

Once outside, Huang Xiao Li returned to the carriage while Yuan gathered with the other bodyguards.

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Chapter 673: Huang Family

“My name is Huang Chen, head of the Huang Family. Inside the carriage is my wife, son, and daughter. Your mission is simple—to make sure no harm comes into their way until we arrive at our destination, the Giant’s Continent.”

“It’s about 100,000 miles from here to the Giant’s Continent, but with the ship we’re riding, it will only take a little over a week to get there, and as mentioned, you will receive ten million gold coins for your service.”

“We will give you one million gold in advance and the rest once we arrive at our destination. Of course, you can get more than ten million gold in total with bonuses depending on your performances.”

“If any of you die while protecting my family, I will make sure to pass your money to your family for you.”

“Do any of you have any questions?”

None of the guards said anything.

“Good, then we’ll make our departure in an hour. We’ll be waiting for you at dock number 9. If you’re all ready before then, we can leave early.”

Huang Chen entered the carriage afterward and left the scene without waiting for them.

And since Yuan had nothing else to do, he immediately followed them to the docks.

There were five other bodyguards besides Yuan that had passed the test, four men and one woman, and they were all between the seventh level and

eighth level Spirit Lord.

An hour later, everyone gathered at dock number 9.

The carriage was nowhere to be seen and the Huang Family was revealed in full.

There was Huang Chen, a middle-aged man with a slightly handsome appearance. Then there was Huang Xiao Li, a pretty young lady around Yuan's age. The last two were a beautiful middle-aged woman and a little boy around seven years old.

They began lining up to board the ship shortly after everyone gathered.

Yuan looked at the front of the ship with interest as they waited to board, as there was a large serpent wrapped around the front of the ship as decoration.

"This ship is called the Raging Serpent. It's the fastest ship available here." Huang Xiao Li said when she noticed Yuan staring at the ship.

"Is this your first time riding on a ship?"

Yuan nodded, "Yes."

"I see... Let's hope it won't be our last," she said, surprising him with such dark words.

After waiting around for about ten minutes, Yuan and the Huang Family were finally allowed onboard the massive ship.

The Huang Family then led them to their living quarters.

"My family and I will be living in this room— room 112. As for you guys, I have managed to arrange two rooms— room 240 and 241. I would have given each of you your own room if I could, but there wasn't enough room available, so you'll have to share. Anyways, each room can fit four people. You guys can decide the rest for yourselves."

“Now for your job as our bodyguard. As long as there’s someone in this room, two of you will guard the entrance at all times. If one of us decides to leave the room for whatever reason, there will be two guards for one person at all times. Any questions?”

They all shook their heads.

“Good.” Huang Chen and his family entered their room shortly after.

“So how should we share the room?” One of the bodyguards there asked.

“Isn’t it obvious? I will take one room and the rest of you will share the other one,” said the female bodyguard.

“Didn’t you hear what Senior Huang said? We can only fit four in a room!”

“You’ll make it work,” she shrugged in an uncaring manner.

“This is why women are—”

“It’s fine, I don’t need to stay in the room.” Yuan suddenly interrupted.

“Then where are you going to rest?”

“I don’t intend on resting. I will be guarding this room until we arrive at our destination,” he said.

After all, he couldn’t risk the Huang Family getting harmed while he was resting in another room.

“You really want that bonus, huh? I admire your dedication. Alright, I will guard this room with you,” said a bulky man with muscles that looked like they were fortified with steel.

The other bodyguards didn’t try to fight for their position since they rather do less work.

Once the other guard left the scene, Yuan and the bulky man sat in front of room 112 like guard dogs.

“What’s your name, young man?” The bulky man asked him.

“Yuan.”

“I’m Qin Kai. How did you manage to get the Huang Family to accept you as their bodyguard as a Spirit Grandmaster? I thought they were only accepting Spirit Lords.”

Qin Kai was the last person to be recruited by the Huang Family, so he didn’t witness Yuan’s commotion or how he was accepted.

Yuan smiled and said, “I convinced them with my sword.”

Qin Kai stared at Yuan with a somewhat gawking look for a moment before laughing out loud, “With your sword, huh? I like you!”

After chatting with each other for a few minutes, they stopped talking to cultivate.

The ship departed from the docks about half an hour after everyone boarded, but Yuan didn’t notice it due to how still the place was.

‘I have an entire week... My cultivation should go up a few levels while I am here...’ Yuan thought to himself as he started absorbing the rich spiritual energy in the air.

However, he found it incredibly difficult to concentrate because memories of his past life would flow into his head while he tried to cultivate.

He eventually gave up trying to cultivate and focused on these memories.

“Welcome to the Immortal Monastery, where we make immortals out of mortals like you. However, you will not become disciples immediately. All of you will start out as servants, and if you can learn our cultivation technique that we provide to you in less than four years, you will be promoted to being an Outer Court disciple.” The old man that picked them up from their village said as they approached the mountain range.

Chapter 674: Sea Demons

Once they entered the sect, the Cultivator left them in a secluded area before flying away without saying another word.

While Yuan and the others looked around, a chubby old man approached them and said, “Welcome to the Bamboo Garden. This is where you will all be spending your next four years. While you are here, you are required to do labor for the sect, such as cutting wood and gathering water. Of course, if you manage to learn the cultivation technique before then, you’ll get to leave earlier.”

“Your schedule will be very simple. There will be a quota for each of you every week that must be completed, or you will be punished. I don’t care when you finish it. You can finish it on the first day of the week or even the last day of the week. As long as you meet your quota, you can spend the rest of your time cultivating. Any questions? Oh, you can call me Senior Kou.”

“Good. Follow me, I will show you the important facilities before I take you all to receive your uniforms and cultivation technique.”

Yuan and the others began following this fat old man through the Bamboo Garden.

“This area right here is the cafeteria. It will only be open two times a day for breakfast and dinner. If you fail to complete your quota, you will lose access to the cafeteria until you finish it.”

“This is the Bamboo Stream. You can wash your clothes here. If you go a little further down, you can even catch fishes. Do not gather your water here for your quotas. There is a separate area for that.”

“That building over there is the training hall. You can go there to train your body, but there won’t be any instructors to give you guidance. That is a privilege only for official disciples.”

“This entire area is the Bamboo Field. It’s where you’ll gather most of your supplies when you receive a quota that requires you to cut down bamboo.”

After spending almost the entire day walking around the Bamboo Garden, Senior Kou led them to their final stop for the day.

“This is the administration building. If you have any problems, you can come here to get it resolved. It’s also where you obtain uniforms if you somehow destroy your old ones. Of course, it won’t be free.”

“As for how you acquire money in this place— you will receive some money every time you complete your quota, and if you do more than you were requested, you will receive a bonus.”

“Senior Kou, I have a question.” Someone there suddenly raised his hand.

“What is it?”

“What else requires money in this place? Do we also have to pay for our food?”

“Food and rent will be for free. However, you will have to pay for everything else. If you get hurt and require medicine, you will need money. If your uniforms become unusable, you will need money to buy new ones.”

“Hell, if you somehow manage to collect enough money, you can even request to buy some cultivation treasures to increase your chances of becoming a Cultivator. However, that will take years if not decades of saving, and if you are still a mortal by then, you might as well give up.”

Sometime later, Yuan and the others were each given 2 sets of uniforms and a single cultivation technique.

“Basic Qi Gathering Technique...” Yuan read the name of the scroll in his grasp.

“Does anyone here not have two sets of uniforms and a cultivation technique?” Senior Kou asked them.

When nobody responded, he nodded and said, “Good, then let’s get you all settled in your new home.”

About an hour later, Senior Kou stopped before a split path with two different paths.

“The female’s living quarters will be on the left and the men’s living quarters will be on the right. Neither will be allowed to go to the other’s living quarters without permission. If you’re caught doing so, you will be punished severely. Keep this in mind.”

“You may now leave. There will be someone to assign your rooms when you arrive.”

The people there thanked Senior Kou for his time before going to their respective paths.

“Good luck, Tian Yang.” Meng Lili said to Yuan before she went to the left path.

“I will see you later.” Yuan nodded.

Dong!

A sudden earthquake stopped Yuan from looking through his memories.

‘What the? Why is there an earthquake? We should be on water!’ Yuan cried inwardly as he looked around with a puzzled face.

It was at this moment a voice resounded everywhere in the ship.

“We have encountered a Sea Demon, but there is no need to panic, as our experts are currently taking care of it as we speak.”

“What is a Sea Demon?” Yuan turned to ask Qin Kai.

“Oh, they’re basically magical beasts that live in the water. They are very common in this part of the ocean, and they can be quite dangerous if not dealt with quickly. We’ll definitely encounter many more of those until we reach our destination.”

“How powerful are they?” Yuan asked with an intrigued look on his face, as he has never heard of monsters existing in the sea before.

“The ones dwelling on the surface of the ocean aren’t much of an issue. A single Spirit Lord can deal with them. However, it’s those that usually dwell in the deeper parts of the ocean that we should be worried about, as they sometimes wander to the surface for whatever reason, and those will require a Spirit King if not multiple Spirit Kings to handle.”

“Furthermore, the closer we get to the Giant’s Continent, the more dangerous the sea creatures become, especially the Leviathans. Let’s pray to the heavens that we don’t encounter those monsters. They’re known as the lord of the seas, and meeting even a single one of them could mean disaster if not certain death for us.”

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Chapter 675: Three Years

The ship stopped shaking shortly after the voice disappeared.

“Looks like they have managed to deal with the Sea Demon.” Qin Kai said before going back to his cultivation.

Yuan also closed his eyes and returned to looking through his memories.

A few weeks have passed since he became a servant of the Immortal Monastery, yet he hasn't been able to learn the cultivation technique, which is a far cry from Yuan's ability to learn even Heaven-rank techniques within minutes.

“Haaaa... Becoming a Cultivator is much more tedious than I'd anticipated... I have read through the manual over a thousand times by now, and I can even recall every single word in the manual backwards with my eyes closed, yet I still cannot sense any spiritual energy.”

Yuan placed the scroll down and tried to sense the spiritual energy in the air again but to no avail.

After failing to sense spiritual energy for half of the day, Yuan decided to go outside to do his quota, which required him to cut down 200 bamboo in a week.

“How are you feeling, Tian Yang? Still can't sense spiritual energy?”

Someone called out to him as he was working.

Yuan turned around to see a skinny young man who looked incredibly fragile approaching him from behind.

This fragile-looking young man was Ning Zixun, a friend he'd made the same day he came to this place.

"I should be asking you that question. Do you feel like dying yet?"

Ning Zixun laughed at his words and said, "Don't be discouraged. It normally takes at least a year or two for most people before they can sense spiritual energy. We just got here less than a month ago. How can we possibly already sense spiritual energy? We're not geniuses."

"At least a year? Hmph! I am not like 'most people'! I will sense spiritual energy in less than a year and become a Cultivator so that I can leave this place!" Yuan declared.

"Why are you in such a hurry to leave? This place isn't even that bad. Although the labor can sometimes get tiring, everything else is great. The food is amazing. The bed is warm, albeit a little small and firm. We even get to practice a cultivation technique for free! Do you have any idea how expensive they are outside?"

"We can work for the rest of our lives and still won't be able to afford the lowest rank cultivation techniques!" Ning Zixun said.

Yuan shook his head and said, "Ning Zixun, if you wish to remain here forever as a servant, you can be my guest. However, I want to become a Cultivator as soon as possible and start growing stronger. Every day I cannot sense spiritual energy is another day that I am powerless!"

Ning Zixun shrugged, "Even if you say that, it's not like we can force our progress to move faster just because we want it to. I wish the world worked that way, but alas, reality is harsh."

Time passed very quickly in the Bamboo Garden, and in the blink of an eye, half a year passed.

"Hey! Tian Yang! Did you hear? One of the girls managed to sense spiritual energy and became a Cultivator! She's now accepted as an official disciple

and will be moved to the outer court with the other official disciples!” Ning Zixun revealed this news to him.

“Really? Who is this genius?” Yuan asked.

“I believe her name was Meng... Meng Li?”

“Meng Lili...” Yuan muttered in a low voice.

“That’s right! Meng Lili! You know her?”

Yuan sighed and nodded with a bittersweet smile on his face.

“We came from the same village, and we were friends back there.”

“How lucky. You’re now friends with an outer court disciple. Maybe she’ll even help you in the near future.”

“I doubt it.”

“Anyways, can you leave me alone for a while. I have a feeling that I am close to sensing spiritual energy.” Yuan then said.

Ning Zixun nodded, “Good luck.”

“You as well.”

After Ning Zixun left the scene, Yuan proceeded to stare at the space in front of him for many minutes in a dazed manner.

“Congratulations, Meng Lili. You’re no longer powerless. However, don’t be so proud of yourself just because you managed to become a Cultivator before me! The cultivation path is not a short race but a long marathon! I will follow in your steps soon and even surpass you! Just watch!”

Yuan began studying the cultivation technique with even more intensity starting that day, almost obsessively so.

However, despite his efforts, it took him until his third year in the Bamboo Garden before he could start sensing spiritual energy and becoming an official disciple.

During this time, his friend Ning Zixun had passed away due to natural causes. Ning Zixun was born with a weak body, yet he endured many years of hard labor just for a chance to become a Cultivator.

It was also shortly after Ning Zixun's death that Yuan managed to successfully sense spiritual energy.

"It's truly a pity that you can't be here to see me in this uniform, Ning Zixun..." Yuan sighed as he stood in front of Ning Zixun's empty residence while wearing the outer court's uniform.

"However, even though I have finally managed to become an official disciple, I don't feel any happiness. Is it because of how long it took me to reach this point? I was so confident that I would succeed in less than a year, but here I am, three years later..."

"It shouldn't be too late to catch up to Meng Lili even now, right? I wonder how far she's progressed in these three years. With her talents, she might even be an inner court disciple now. Guess I will find out once I move to the outer court."

After saying his goodbyes to Ning Zixun and the place, Yuan left the Bamboo Garden and was taken to the outer court by the same person who brought him to this sect, unaware of the countless challenges that were waiting for him there.

Chapter 676: Too Easy

BOOM!

The ship suddenly began shaking violently for a second time, snapping Yuan out of his daze.

“Wow, this one is quite powerful. Did we encounter a powerful Sea Demon already? We’ve only been out in the sea for half a day.” Qin Kai muttered in a low voice.

The shaking lasted a few more moments more than the previous time.

“Half a day...?” Yuan suddenly realized something, and he tilted his head to look up into the ceiling of the ship.

“Meixiu, Lulu, I won’t be logging off until I finish this trial. Please take care of everything until I am done.” He spoke to them in the spectators’ room.

“Who are you talking to?” Qin Kai also looked at the ceiling with raised eyebrows.

“Oh, I was just talking to myself.”

“What a weirdo.” Qin Kai chuckled.

Meanwhile, in the spectators’ room, Meixiu said to Chu Liuxiang, “I am going to log off. What about you?”

“I will stay here and continue watching Yuan in case anything happens.”

Meixiu’s eyebrows twitched slightly when she realized something.

‘She’s no longer addressing him as ‘Brother Yuan’... Did something happen between them?’

“Okay, then I will check up on you once in a while.”

Meixiu logged off shortly after to notify the other members that Yuan will be busy for a week.

“A week? What’s he doing inside Cultivation Online that requires so much time?” Wang Ming asked out of curiosity.

“He’s challenging the Stairway to Heaven right now.”

“Oh, I have heard of that place. It’s where Cultivators go to ascend to the next world, right?”

Meixiu nodded.

“Alright. Training is going to be a bit boring without him, but it’s only a week. Thank you for letting us know.”

Everybody accepted the news without much problem.

Two days passed in the blink of an eye for Yuan, who was constantly cultivating and looking through his memories.

The ship shook over a dozen times over the last two days, but the warriors hired by the ship had managed to deal with the Sea Demons without any problem.

Besides the shaking from time to time, Yuan’s trial has been very relaxing — suspiciously so.

This made him wonder if the real trial was at the Giant’s Continent.

However, that peace would end soon.

“We have company. Be alert.” Qin Kai suddenly said to him in a low voice.

Yuan opened his eyes to see a group of people that had the appearance of mercenaries slowly approaching their direction.

One look and anybody can tell that they were trouble.

Both Yuan and Qin Kai stood up.

“What do you want?” Qin Kai asked them with his massive arms crossed over his chest, looking very threatening and defensive.

The man leading the group smiled and said, “Is this the Huang Family’s room? We’re actually here for a business appointment.”

“Business appointment? How come I didn’t hear anything about such a thing?”

“This is a very important and exclusive business opportunity for the Huang Family. Why would they let some bodyguards know about it?” The man scoffed.

Qin Kai looked at them up and down and smiled, “If you wear that kind of getup to a business meeting, I doubt it’ll work out for you. Let me save you all from embarrassment. Get out of my face.”

“Imprudent bastard. I gave you a chance to live, yet you willingly choose death.” The man and his group withdrew their weapons the next moment.

Qin Kai laughed and said, “Even if you manage to kill us and steal from the Huang Family, where are you guys going to hide? We’re in the middle of the sea. You’ll die way before you can return to the docks even if you fly.”

“Who said anything about hiding or running away? Once we deal with the Huang Family, we’ll seize control of the ship and take our time robbing the other passengers. Ships heading to the Giant’s Continent are always filled with wealthy people and loaded with treasures.”

“Do you idiots think you’re the first to rob the Raging Serpent? There have been countless attempts to rob this place, and all of them never managed to return to the land.”

“Hmph! Enough talking! Get rid of them!” The man pointed at Yuan and Qin Kai as he ordered his group.

“Heavenly Domain!”

Yuan immediately used his domain to restrict their movements, but since they were all Spirit Lords, it couldn’t completely seal their movements.

“This guy can use a domain! Let’s get him first!” The man shouted.

“If you want to get to him, you’ll have to get past me first!”

Qin Kai stood before the robbers and Yuan.

While Qin Kai distracted them, Yuan used the soundless blade to kill them from a distance, killing many of the robbers before they even realized what was happening.

The battle was a one-sided slaughter, and in just a couple of minutes, Yuan had managed to kill all of the robbers.

Qin Kai stared at him with wide eyes afterward.

“I completely understand why the Huang Family hired you now...” He mumbled in a dumbfounded voice.

“What are we going to do with these bodies?” Yuan asked a moment later.

“The cleaning crew will take care of them.” Qin Kai shrugged.

Yuan raised his eyebrows.

“It’s common for robbers to sneak onto this ship, and it’s also common for them to die.”

And sure enough, the cleaning crew arrived a few minutes later to pick up the corpses and clean the blood, almost like they were used to it.

As for what they did with the corpses, they simply tossed them into the ocean for the Sea Demons to feast on.

After the commotion, Huang Chen opened the door and asked them about the situation.

Qin Kai recalled everything that happened to him.

Huang Chen nodded with a satisfied face.

“Good job,” he said to them, but he was mostly looking at Yuan.

However, Yuan was feeling uneasy about how easy his trial has been so far. These robbers were just like the guards from the previous trial. They were only there to exhaust his spiritual energy before the real fight.

He can only imagine what the second trial has in store for him.

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Chapter 677: Array Master

On the third day of their journey to the Giant's Continent, Huang Xiao Li came out of her room and pointed at Yuan, who was casually sitting in front of the door and said to him, "I am going to look around the ship, and you'll be coming with me, Yuan."

"What?" Yuan was dumbfounded by her request.

"You encountered robbers just yesterday and you already want to leave your room? That's a little dangerous if I have to be honest," he said to her.

Furthermore, he didn't want to be separated from the rest of the family. What if they're attacked when he's away and dies? That would mean the end of the trial for him!

"I will be fine. After all, you will be there to protect me if anything were to happen, right?" Huang Xiao Li said with a smile on her face.

"What about the rest of your family? I have to protect them as well."

"Have you already forgotten that we have other bodyguards beside you? They will take your spot. Or are you making this difficult because you don't want to be with me? Do you find me bothersome?"

"That's not it..." Yuan sighed.

"Then it's decided! You're coming with me to explore the ship!"

Yuan gave up and nodded his head, "But we still need another bodyguard."

Qin Kai raised his hand and said, "I can—"

However, he was quickly interrupted by Huang Xiao Li, “I have already spoken to my father. I can take just one bodyguard with me. You can go confirm with him if you’d like.”

“That won’t be necessary. We trust your words.” Qin Kai said.

He then turned to look at Yuan and said, “Go ahead and protect the young lady. I will call one of the other guards to take your place until you return.”

“Thank you.” Yuan nodded.

After waiting for his replacement to show up, Yuan followed Huang Xiao Li around the ship.

“I heard that you took care of the robbers yesterday.” Huang Xiao Li spoke as they walked.

“Yes, but I wasn’t the only person who took care of them. Qin Kai was also there,” he said.

“The bodyguard that was with you, right? But you killed the most. Even though you’re only a Spirit Master. I’m impressed.”

“Thank you.”

“You don’t belong to a sect, right?”

“Not at this moment.”

“Why don’t you join my sect after this journey? I think you’ll do very well there with your talents.”

“I will consider it.”

“Really?” Huang Xiao Li appeared to be surprised by Yuan’s response, as she didn’t think he would even consider her random request.

Little did she know that he’d only agreed because he knew that she would disappear after he finishes this trial and that none of them were real.

“Anyways, we can talk about my sect after we finish our business at the Giant’s Continent. I don’t want to burst your bubbles, but the robbers yesterday are not the reason we hired you guys, as we could’ve dealt with them by ourselves.”

“I figured as much.” Yuan showed a bittersweet smile.

“Then why did you hire us? And where did that peak Spirit Lord bodyguard go?”

“Are you talking about Dong Zhou? He’s currently part of the ship’s protection squad, so he’s dealing with the Sea Demons.”

“I see...”

“We hired extra bodyguards not because of robbers. We did so because we need as many hands as we can get once we arrive at the Giant’s Continent,” she said.

“The Giant’s Continent? Is it that dangerous there?” Yuan asked.

“Yes, but it’s not the giants that are dangerous. It’s the magical beasts that dwell there that are the most threatening.”

“By the way, why are you asking about Dong Zhou? Do you wish to speak with him?”

Yuan nodded and said, “I wanted to learn a little more about arrays and formations and I thought that he could help me. That’s all.”

“Arrays? If that’s the only reason why you’re seeking for him, then you can just ask me. I may not look like it, but I am also an Array Master! In fact, our entire family specializes in arrays and formations!” Huang Xiao Li revealed this fact.

“Really?” Yuan looked at her with a surprised face.

“Does it look like I am joking?” Huang Xiao Li suddenly lifted her hand to show Yuan the beautiful symbol floating on the top of her palm.

“That’s an array?” Yuan asked as he stared at the symbol with interest.

“Not exactly. This is an array symbol. You’ll need multiple symbols to create an array. Like this.”

Huang Xiao Li created a few more symbols afterward, overlapping them with each other until they formed one large symbol.

Once her array was completed, Huang Xiao Li tossed it at Yuan.

“What did you just do to me?” Yuan searched his body but didn’t feel any different.

Huang Xiao Li didn’t say anything and withdrew a small dagger before slashing it at him.

Yuan subconsciously used his bare arm to block it since he was surprised by her sudden actions.

However, the dagger didn’t manage to cut his skin even though the blade slid across his skin.

“I just cast a protective array on your body. You’re pretty much untouchable by normal weapons and treasures to a certain extent now.”

“Wow... You surprised me for a moment there...” Yuan sighed.

“Anyways, that was amazing.”

“Thank you, but that was just the very basics. If you have any questions, I will be happy to answer them.” Huang Xiao Li said as they approached the bow of the ship.

“Was it difficult learning arrays? How would you compare it to learning a cultivation technique?”

Huang Xiao Li smiled and said, “Learning arrays is much more difficult than learning cultivation techniques, almost incomparably so. If it takes the

average mortal a year to become a Cultivator, then it would take the average Cultivator ten years to become an Array Master.”

“Do you want to try?” She suddenly asked.

“Eh? Try what?”

“Try learning arrays. Of course, you won’t actually learn it in such a short time, but you’ll get a feel for it.”

After pondering for a moment, Yuan nodded, “Let’s do it.”

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Chapter 678: Learning About Arrays

“Alright, let’s start with the array I just used on you.” Huang Xiao Li retrieved a manual and showed it to him.

“Body Shielding Array...” Yuan read the title of the manual.

“How does one learn arrays? Is it any different from learning cultivation techniques?” He then asked.

“Well, they’re quite similar in some ways, but they are also very different. You will understand it once we begin.”

“Anyways, let’s start.”

“First and foremost, you must learn how to create symbols with your hands. Allow me to demonstrate it.”

Huang Xiao Li then raised her hand and began writing in the air with her index finger.

There was a warm-looking light on the tip of her fingers, and everywhere it went, it would draw a line in the air, eventually creating a symbol that floated in the air.

“I don’t expect you to draw a symbol on your first try, so you should just try drawing lines in the air like this.”

She then waved her finger around, creating a long, glowing line in the air.

“In order to do this, you must collect your spiritual energy on your finger tip and imagine drawing in the air. Trust me, it’s actually much harder than it sounds. Just mastering this technique alone requires months of practice.”

“Okay, let me try.”

Yuan closed his eyes and gathered some of his spiritual energy onto his finger tip.

He could immediately feel a subtle but warm feeling on his finger tip, and without opening his eyes, he waved his hand around like a music conductor while imagining lines would appear wherever his fingers moved.

Huang Xiao Li’s eyes widened with shock when she saw the glowing line that followed Yuan’s finger in the air.

The line was incredibly smooth and consistent, almost like it was created by an expert with countless years of experience.

‘H-He actually managed to succeed on his first try?!’ She cried inwardly.

Huang Xiao Li herself was considered to be a rare genius that hasn’t been seen in over a thousand years, and it took her an entire month to draw in the air so perfectly.

“A-Are you sure this is your first time? I’m having a hard time believing that you’re a beginner with no experience,” she said to him.

“Eh? Yes, this is my first time. I didn’t even know about Array Masters until very recently,” he nodded his head.

‘He’s not lying...’ Huang Xiao Li thought to herself as she stared at Yuan in the eyes.

‘So a prodigy like him can exist in this world, huh...’

A slight smile appeared on her face.

“Anyways, let’s move onto the second step since you can already draw perfectly.”

“Now for the hard part, you must learn to draw symbols and combine them into a single array. It’s a process that cannot be explained due to its complexity, but this should help you.”

Huang Xiao Li retrieved two more manuals and handed them to Yuan.

“10,000 Array Symbols... Guide to Combining Array Symbols...”

Yuan read the title of these manuals out loud.

“There are actually more than 10,000 array symbols in existence, but these 10,000 symbols are the most basic and what beginners must remember first.”

“If you think about it, arrays resemble alchemy more than it does cultivation. In alchemy, you must remember the ingredients and learn the recipes to create pills. As an Array Master, you must memorize the array symbols and the array combinations to create an array.”

“Most of the basic arrays require between fifty to one hundred symbols. Although that may seem like a lot, even amateur Array Masters can make over ten symbols in less than a second. After all, once you’re experienced enough, you can create symbols without needing to draw it with your fingers, and you can just create them almost instantaneously like this.”

Huang Xiao Li showed her palms and symbols quickly began appearing on it, almost as though they were coming out of thin air.

“At my level, I can create around four hundred symbols in a second. It’s pretty good for someone my age, but I cannot compare to some of the true experts out there that can create thousands of symbols almost instantaneously.”

“I see... Thank you for teaching me about arrays.” Yuan said.

She smiled and said, “Since I taught you about arrays, I am technically your Master now.”

Yuan chuckled and bowed to her before speaking in a joking manner, “This disciple greets Master.”

“Alright, I have seen enough of this side. Let’s go check out the other side of the ship before we go back.” Huang Xiao Li said a moment later.

“Okay.”

The two of them proceeded walking to the other side of the ship.

Bang!

The ship suddenly began shaking.

“It’s a Sea Demon! Let’s take a closer look!” Huang Xiao Li said with an excited face.

“Are you sure? That sounds dangerous...” Yuan said with a slightly worried frown on his face.

She smiled and said, “Don’t worry, there’s a powerful formation protecting this ship, and Sea Demons cannot get within 250 meters of the ship, so even though the ship is shaking, it’s not as though the ship is being physically attacked.”

“Follow me!”

Huang Xiao Li began running through the ship, stopping a few moments later.

“Look out there!” She pointed to the sea.

Yuan looked at where she was pointing, and sure enough, there was a battle occurring about 250 meters away from the ship.

There were seven Cultivators with a Spirit Lord cultivation out there currently battling against these large and thick tentacles that were sticking out of the water.

“Judging by the size of those tentacles... A medium-size Sea Demon, huh?” Huang Xiao Li mumbled.

“Oh! Look! There’s Dong Zhou!” She pointed at the person hovering above the battle.

Even though it looked like he wasn’t part of the battle, he was actually supporting the others with his arrays by enhancing their defenses and boosting their strength, and from time to time, he would try to restrict the movements of the tentacles.

“So that’s how an Array Master fights, huh?” Yuan mumbled as he watched their battle from afar.

Chapter 679: Incoming Sea Demon

“There are many ways an Array Master can fight. They can support the others like Dong Zhou is doing right now, or they can fight in the frontline by themselves. It all depends on what they prefer and how confident they are in their own arrays.”

“Some Array Masters may prefer supporting because they are not confident in their ability to fight, but that is not to say they don’t have the capabilities to do so.” Huang Xiao Li explained to him.

Bang!

The ship shook again when one of the tentacles struck the barrier protecting the ship.

“I didn’t notice the formation until you told me. How can you tell there’s one?” Yuan then asked.

“Formations can be spotted quite easily if you know what you’re looking for. Unless the formation is concealed with another formation, you should be able to see it with your divine sense.”

“With my divine sense?” Yuan immediately tried looking with his divine sense, and sure enough, there was a massive barrier around the ship that seems to be made of symbols— tens of thousands of symbols that connect with each other.

“You probably think there’s only a few thousand symbols in this formation, right? Look at the symbols individually again. Each of these symbols are actually combinations of smaller symbols, so there are millions if not billions of symbols that make up this formation.”

“Heavens... How long would it take to create this formation?” Yuan asked after a moment of silence.

“Hmmm... It really depends on the complexity of the formation and the ability of those Formation Experts that worked on it. A formation of this size and complexity probably took years if not decades of efforts from hundreds of Formation Experts to complete.”

“That long?!” Yuan was shocked.

“Of course. Formations often require millions of symbols, and a single mistake can cause the whole formation to crumble. Unlike arrays that don’t need as much attention since they require much fewer symbols, so even if you make a mistake, you can quickly fix it.”

“Furthermore, arrays are meant to be used very quickly and do not have lasting effects. Formations, on the other hand, are often made to last for as long as possible. There are plenty of formations out there that have lasted for even millions of years.”

“How does one become a Formation Expert? Is it the same as becoming an Array Master?” Yuan asked.

“In a way, yes. However, most people become Array Masters before they become Formation Experts. Although formation requires symbols, formations have their own unique symbols while arrays have their own distinctive symbols. That’s what really separates us apart from being completely the same thing. The basics are the same, but everything else is different.”

“I understand now. Thank you for the lecture.” Yuan said.

The Sea Demon was subdued shortly after their conversation ended.

“Hm? Young Lady, what are you doing out here?” Dong Zhou noticed them when he made his way back to the ship.

“It’s suffocating to stay in the same room for many days, so I came out for some fresh air,” she said.

Dong Zhou nodded and said, “Anyways, you should return to your room soon. The captain said we might encounter a large-size Sea Demon soon since we’re getting closer to the Giant’s Continent.”

“It’s just a large-size Sea Demon. It won’t be the first time we encounter them.”

“No, this time is different. I’m not sure what to expect since we’ve never had a reading like this one before, but the captain said to expect the worst.”

“Reading?” Yuan raised his eyebrows.

“Yes, we have a treasure that allows us to detect nearby Sea Demons and those that show aggression towards us. The radar picked up the aura of a large Sea Demon that’s currently approaching our direction, but we’ve never seen such a reading of spiritual energy before.”

“How long before this Sea Demon reaches us?” Yuan asked with a worried frown, as he was certain that this Sea Demon was the real trial.

“At the speed it’s moving, it should collide with us in two days.” Dong Zhou said.

“Two days...” Yuan mumbled to himself.

Dong Zhou left the scene shortly after.

“Are you worried about this Sea Demon?” Huang Xiao Li could see it very clearly on Yuan’s face.

“Yes.”

“No matter what we encounter, I’m sure we’ll be able to overcome it,” she smiled.

“I sure hope so.”

They returned to the room after finishing up their tour around the ship.

“Welcome back.” Qin Kai said to them when they returned.

Yuan looked at his replacement and said, “Thank you for taking over. I will take care of the rest.”

“Of course.”

The bodyguard didn’t say anything else and returned to his room.

“I feel safe knowing that you’re here, Yuan.” Huang Xiao Li said to him with a gentle smile before entering the room.

“I think she has a thing for you.” Qin Kai said to him afterward.

Yuan merely shook his head and ignored it.

He then sat down and retrieved the manuals that Huang Xiao Li had given him and started studying them.

He started with reading through ‘Guide to Combining Array Symbols’ to memorizing all of the symbols in ‘10,000 Array Symbols’.

Meanwhile, in the spectators’ room.

“The Young Master is learning arrays now? How many cultivation paths does he plan on walking? Isn’t it bad to spread your focus to so many different things at once?” Feng Yuxiang mumbled in a dumbfounded voice.

“Brother Yuan is not your average genius.” Xiao Hua said.

“I am well aware of that, but he’ll grow much faster if he focuses on one thing.”

Chu Liuxiang then said, “Well, there’s no harm in picking up different hobbies. It’s easy to get bored of doing the same thing over and over again. The real question is whether he truly invests himself into this new hobby or not. He might even get bored of it after a while.”

“Brother Yuan will probably master whatever he’s interested in very quickly and move onto the next path.” Xiao Hua said.

“Honestly, whenever the Young Master does something new, it feels more like he already has experience doing them but just forgot about it. I know that sounds impossible, but it’s how it feels sometimes.” Feng Yuxiang shrugged.

After a moment of silence, Xiao Hua mumbled in a low voice, “If reincarnation is real, that won’t sound as impossible...”

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Chapter 680: Sea Demon Identified

“Reincarnation? Do you believe the Young Master is the reincarnation of a powerful immortal in the past? Do you even believe in the concept of reincarnation at all?” Feng Yuxiang looked at Xiao Hua with raised eyebrows.

Xiao Hua didn’t appear to be the type to believe in these kinds of things.

After a moment of silence, Xiao Hua spoke, “Although Xiao Hua doesn’t necessarily believe in reincarnation, her family believes in it.”

“Your family? I have been wondering for a while now, but what kind of family do you have?”

“...”

As Feng Yuxiang expected, Xiao Hua refused to say anything about her family.

“Whatever. Not that I really care. Anyways, if the Young Master is really the reincarnation of a powerful expert, I believe it. After all, I am a phoenix — I symbolize reincarnation itself.”

Chu Liuxiang listened to their conversation with raised eyebrows.

Although she doesn’t believe in reincarnation, she found the topic to be quite interesting.

This was also the case for Min Li.

“Let’s say Yuan is the reincarnation of someone else... Is there a way to test that?” Chu Liuxiang suddenly asked.

“There are many mythical treasures in the world of cultivation, right? Surely, there must be a treasure that can tell whether someone is reincarnated or not.”

Feng Yuxiang pondered for a moment before speaking, “Actually, there’s one. However, it’s only a legend.”

“It’s called the Mirror of Samsara. Legend has it that anyone that stands in front of this mirror will have their past lives revealed by the mirror.”

“It’s only a legend? From my experience, all legends turn out to be just that — legends...” Chu Liuxiang sighed.

“Actually, the Mirror of Samsara really exists. The legend is that it can tell one’s past lives.” Feng Yuxiang said.

“If the treasure exists, why does this legend still exist?”

“Probably because nobody can confirm it. The Mirror of Samsara is being kept by a powerful collector who doesn’t allow anyone near his treasures, so even though the treasure exists, it’s not accessible, hence the legend.”

“The collector is probably doing it on purpose to keep the treasure rarer than its actual value, so when it’s time to sell the treasure, it’ll earn much more money. It’s a pretty common tactic for collectors.” Chu Liuxiang shrugged.

“You seem to know a lot about this topic. Are you also a collector?” Feng Yuxiang asked.

“No, but my family is.”

After a moment of silence, Chu Liuxiang asked, “Let’s hypothetically say that Yuan is reincarnated. What will you all do?”

Feng Yuxiang smiled and said, “Nothing. Once someone dies, their identity and everything else dies with them, so even if the Young Master is reincarnated, it won’t affect him or change who he currently is.”

Xiao Hua nodded, “Brother Yuan is Brother Yuan no matter who he was in his previous life.”

“Is that so...”

They returned to watching the pond shortly after.

The following day, Yuan opened his eyes when there was another announcement in the ship.

“This is an emergency! I repeat, this is an emergency! There is currently a large-size Sea Demon heading towards our direction, and it is very likely that it’s a Leviathan! We will need the cooperation of everyone on the ship if it really turns out to be a Leviathan! Please prepare yourselves!”

Everybody on the ship began to freak out after they heard the announcement.

“A Leviathan is coming?! How can we possibly fight that monster?!”

“We’re dead! We’re all dead!”

“Fuck... I think I jinxed it for us...” Qin Kai rubbed his temples in a stressful manner.

“They said it might be a Leviathan. It’s not confirmed yet.” Yuan said.

“I know, but there’s a good chance that it’s a Leviathan.”

“How powerful is a Leviathan?”

“Most of them are as powerful as a mid-level to peak-level Spirit King. Some of them even have the prowess of a low-level Spirit Emperor. We might barely survive an ordinary Spirit King, but if it has the strength of a Spirit Emperor, we’re all guaranteed to die.” Qin Kai sighed.

“Do we have any Spirit Kings onboard?”

“There is always one or two of them aboard, but even then, we might not defeat a Leviathan. Sea Demons are just like magical beasts in the sense that they’re much more powerful than humans that are at the same level.”

“Strength of a Spirit Emperor...” Yuan muttered in a low voice.

Compared to his last trial, this second trial is definitely more difficult.

Unfortunately, the only thing they can do now is wait and see what this large-size Sea Demon really is.

After another day of anxious waiting and without anyone getting a good sleep, if any at all, the announcement returned, “We have identified the Sea Demon approaching us! It’s— It’s a Leviathan!”

This announcement brought many people on the ship to tears, as their worst nightmares have come true.

However, there was still more to be announced, and it only made people feel more despair.

“Furthermore, it’s not an ordinary Leviathan! It’s a mutated Leviathan— a Flying Leviathan!”

“WHAT?! A FLYING LEVIATHAN?!” Qin Kai exclaimed in a shocked voice.

Seeing Qin Kai’s reaction, Yuan could only swallow nervously.

“The Flying Leviathan will arrive in two hours! We need all Cultivators on the deck now!”

The announcement ended there.

A moment of silence filled the ship, but when that silence ended, chaos erupted, and Yuan could hear screaming and crying coming from every room there.

“Let me guess... a Flying Leviathan has the strength of a low-level Spirit Emperor.” Yuan asked Qin Kai, who slowly nodded his head.

“Unfortunately, that’s not all there is to it. There are many different species when it comes to Leviathans, and the Flying Leviathan is one of the most dangerous types, as they can leave the water and fly around in the sky like a dragon...” Qin Kai continued.

Yuan closed his eyes and released a deep sigh.

“Flying or not... I will not let it stop us from reaching the Giant’s Continent.”

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Chapter 681: I Won't Let You Die

The Huang Family gathered Yuan and the other bodyguards shortly after the announcement regarding the Flying Leviathan.

“As you should all know by now, there is a Flying Leviathan heading our way. This is a life-or-death situation for everyone on the ship, so we’ll need to give it our all to defeat the Flying Leviathan together.” Huang Chen said to them.

Everyone there nodded their heads with serious expressions on their faces.

“Anyways, let’s all head to the deck and see what the captain of this ship has to say to us.”

“Wait.” Yuan suddenly stopped them.

“What’s the matter?”

“I... I need to prepare myself for the Flying Leviathan, so if you don’t mind, I will stay behind.” Yuan said to them.

Huang Chen nodded, “You’ll have two hours to prepare until the Flying Leviathan arrives. Do your best.”

“Father, I will stay here with him.” Huang Xiao Li suddenly said.

Huang Chen raised his eyebrows and pondered for a moment before looking at Yuan. “Do you mind?”

Although he wasn’t sure why his daughter wanted to stay here with Yuan, he didn’t object to it either.

“I don’t mind.” Yuan shook his head.

Everyone but Yuan and Huang Xiao Li gathered at the deck of the ship shortly after.

“Do you mind if I use your room?” Yuan asked Huang Xiao Li when they were alone.

“No, go ahead. I was going to ask you to come with me, anyway.”

“Are you trying to go somewhere?”

“Not exactly.”

Once they entered the room, Huang Xiao Li locked the door behind her.

“I am going to cultivate now.” Yuan said as he looked around for a place to sit.

However, he suddenly heard something falling onto the ground.

It was a gentle sound, so whatever dropped just now was light and soft.

Yuan turned around to make sure everything was okay, and his eyes widened with shock when he saw the scene.

“X-Xiao Li...? What are you doing?” Yuan asked her, who had suddenly stripped naked.

Indeed, what had just dropped onto the floor just now were Huang Xiao Li’s clothes.

“Yuan...” Tears began flowing down Huang Xiao Li’s face as she spoke, “I don’t want to die alone... Before we die... can you make love to me?”

“...” Yuan didn’t know how to respond and silently stared at her crying face.

“T-That vixen! What is she trying to do to my darling with my face?!”
Inside the spectators’ room, Chu Liuxiang became livid when she saw what was happening through the pond.

Even Feng Yuxiang and Min Li were dumbfounded by the situation, as they could’ve never imagined that such a thing would happen during the trial.

As for Xiao Hua, she couldn’t comprehend the situation, hence why she was still relatively calm, only feeling mildly puzzled.

Meanwhile, back in the room, Huang Xiao Li continued with her advances on Yuan.

“Please, Yuan... Even though I am a little desperate, I won’t do this just with anyone... In fact, my body is still pure...”

Huang Xiao Li slowly approached Yuan before spreading her slender arms and embracing him.

“Let’s make love to each other while we still can, until we die, okay...?”
She whispered to his ears in a painful voice.

Yuan closed his eyes and took a deep breath.

He opened his arms and hugged Huang Xiao Li back.

“Is he really going to do it with her?! But she has my face!” Chu Liuxiang felt the urge to cry when she imagined Yuan sleeping with Huang Xiao Li.

However, it was not because he’s sleeping with another woman. It was the fact that Huang Xiao Li had her face that devastated Chu Liuxiang.

“Thank you... Yuan...” Huang Xiao Li said to him.

“I’m sorry, but I cannot fulfill your request.” Yuan suddenly said, dumbfounding her.

“Eh?” She looked at him with her eyes as wide as saucers.

Yuan stared at her in the eyes and said, “You won’t die alone... because I won’t let you die today.”

“B-B-But it’s a Flying Leviathan! There’s no way we could defeat that monster! Nobody has survived a Leviathan’s attack before, much less a Flying Leviathan! It’s impossible!”

“Trust me, I will defeat it.” Yuan said before picking up Huang Xiao Li’s clothes and handing them back to her.

Huang Xiao Li silently looked at her clothes for a long moment before lifting her head to look at Yuan.

She eventually nodded and said, “If I die alone, I will haunt you in your next life so that you will never be able to find a partner, Yuan.”

Yuan’s body trembled when he heard her words that reminded him of Azure.

“I promise.” He smiled.

He then took a seat on the ground before retrieving a small box from his spatial ring.

After putting her clothes back on, Huang Xiao Li asked him, “What is that? How is that going to prepare you for the battle?”

Yuan opened the box, revealing a crystal inside.

“Is that a monster core? You’re going to cultivate that right now? It’s going to take days depending on what kind of monster core it is! We only have two hours before the Flying Leviathan arrives— less than that, actually!”

Yuan smiled and said, “It’s not a monster core, and it won’t take days.”

He opened his mouth and tossed the crystal inside the next moment.

“Wha—?!” Huang Xiao Li was shocked by Yuan’s actions.

‘Wait... Since it’s not a monster core, it should be fine...’ She quickly calmed down.

Yuan could immediately feel the crystal melting in his mouth, and a bitter and somewhat spicy taste quickly followed.

[??? Qi has been absorbed from the Demon Core!]

[You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough!]

[You have reached the sixth level Spirit Grandmaster!]

[+30,000 Stats]

‘An immediate breakthrough?!’ Huang Xiao Li cried inwardly when she sensed his breakthrough.

However, that was not the end of her shock, as Yuan’s cultivation base continued to quickly soar towards Spirit Lord!

“What did he just swallow?” Chu Liuxiang asked out of curiosity.

“That’s the Demon Lord’s Demon Core...” Lan Yingying responded to her question in a dazed voice.

Chapter 682: Spirit Lord

“D-Did you just say ‘demon core’...?” Min Li snapped her head to look at Lan Yingying with a shocked face.

Demons should be extinct, so demon cores should no longer exist. However, if some of them have managed to survive this long, then it would be an incredibly valuable— even priceless treasure!

However, that wasn’t even the most shocking part! Why would Yuan consume something like that? Although she doesn’t know the difference between demon cores and monster cores, they should function the same way, meaning it would be reckless if not suicidal to swallow them!

“Wait... Are people allowed to use treasures while they are challenging the Stairway to Heaven? Isn’t that cheating?” Chu Liuxiang had a different question in mind.

Feng Yuxiang shook her head and said, “As far as I’m aware, it’s not against the rules, or the Young Master would’ve failed already. I guess it’s allowed because the Stairway to Heaven didn’t take into consideration that someone might be able to consume treasures like the Young Master.”

It was at this moment that Meixiu logged into the game.

“Did something happen?” She asked them when she saw their faces.

Chu Liuxiang proceeded to explain to her the situation.

Meanwhile, Yuan had just reached the ninth level of Spirit Grandmaster and was only a single level away from becoming a Spirit Lord!

“Heavens...” Huang Xiao Li was sitting on the floor because her legs had given up on her after she witnessed Yuan’s heaven-defying talents.

After stopping at the peak of Spirit Grandmaster for a few minutes, Yuan suddenly took a deep breath, and when he released it, a cloud of glistening mist would come out of his mouth, almost like he was smoking.

Whoosh!

A sudden gust appeared in the room despite the windows being closed.

[You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough!]

[Because your Qi Experience is already full, you will not be able to receive anymore Qi until you reach the next realm]

[You have met the requirements for a breakthrough]

[You have reached first level Spirit Lord]

[+??? Stats]

[Your ‘Superior Senses’ has developed into ‘Spiritual Senses’]

[You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough!]

[You have reached second level Spirit Lord!]

[+??? Stats!]

Yuan opened his eyes after he reached the second level Spirit Lord, as he’d completely absorbed the demon core at that point.

He stood up and stretched his body, feeling incredibly refreshed and filled with energy.

“A-Are you okay...?” Huang Xiao Li asked him in a nervous voice.

Normally, one would experience backlashes if their cultivation base expands so quickly.

“I am perfectly fine,” he said with a calm smile on his face.

“And I am also ready to fight the Flying Leviathan.”

“B-But the Flying Leviathan has the strength of a low-level Spirit Emperor... You’re still two entire realms below that...” Huang Xiao Li said in a low voice.

“I will manage it somehow. Let’s go meet up with the others now, shall we?”

She nodded.

The two of them proceeded to make their way to the deck of the ship, where every single cultivator onboard was gathered.

“Y-You... You have been suppressing your cultivation base this entire time? I thought it was insane how a Spirit Grandmaster could defeat Spirit Lords with ease! It turns out you’d been a Spirit Lord yourself this entire time!” Qin Kai was dumbfounded to see Yuan suddenly emitting the aura of a Spirit Lord.

Yuan didn’t say anything and merely smiled at his words.

Seeing that he wasn’t saying anything, Huang Xiao Li also decided to keep her mouth shut. They wouldn’t believe her even if she told them the truth, anyway.

“How long until the Flying Leviathan arrives?” Yuan asked them.

“It will arrive in about fifteen minutes,” said Huang Chen.

“I see...”

While they waited, Yuan decided to check his stats since it has been awhile.

However, what he saw immediately left him dumbfounded.

—

Cultivation: Second Level Spirit Lord

Legacy: Great One's Legacy

Bloodline: Immortal Monarch Bloodline

Physique: Heaven Refining Physique

Physical Strength: ???

Mental Strength: ???

Soul Strength: ???

Physical Defense: ???

Mental Defense: ???

Qi Experience: ???/???

“I can't see my stats? Are they too high? Maybe I am advancing much faster than the game anticipated...”

It wasn't his first time seeing these question marks since his Qi Experience has been bugged out after becoming a Spirit Grandmaster. Now that he has become a Spirit Lord, even his character stats have been bugged out.

However, Yuan wasn't worried at all. After all, it wasn't as if his stats were gone. It's just so high that even the system cannot keep up with it.

After waiting anxiously for the Flying Leviathan, the captain's voice suddenly returned.

“The Flying Leviathan is here! Prepare for battle!”

Right after the captain's voice disappeared, Yuan and everyone on the ship could feel a powerful aura suddenly appear in the distance.

This aura was so intense that it instantly knocked those with a weak mental defense unconscious.

Yuan could feel his entire body shivering from fear, but his blood was boiling with excitement for some reason.

"Are we all ready?" Huang Chen asked them.

Everybody there nodded.

"Please wait a moment." Yuan suddenly said.

"What is it?"

They looked at him.

"I would like to apologize," he said.

"Why are you apologizing?" Huang Xiao Li raised her eyebrows in a puzzled manner.

Yuan didn't say anything else and began drawing array symbols with his hand, and before anybody there could react, he activated the array he'd created in less than a second, confining the Huang Family and the bodyguards they hired in a powerful barrier.

"W-What is the meaning of this?!" Huang Chen roared in a furious voice when he thought that Yuan had betrayed them.

"Yuan! Why are you doing this?!" Huang Xiao Li also questioned him.

Yuan took a deep breath before speaking, "You hired me to keep your family safe, and that is what I intend on doing."

"What about us?! We're also hired to protect them! We should be fighting alongside you!" Qin Kai said to him.

Yuan shook his head and said in a calm voice, “Because this isn’t your trial — it’s my trial.”

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Chapter 683: Flying Leviathan

“Please! Yuan! You don’t have to do this alone!” Huang Xiao Li banged on the barrier with her fists.

However, Yuan merely shook his head at her before flying off the ship and towards the Flying Leviathan’s aura with the other cultivators, leaving pretty much just the Huang Family and their bodyguards onboard.

Of course, the mortals and those that cannot fight also remained on the ship while everyone else went to greet the Flying Leviathan far away from the ship so their fight won’t affect the ship and those onboard.

After Yuan left, Huang Xiao Li immediately began trying to destroy the array created by Yuan, but to her absolute shock, she was unable to find any weaknesses in the array, making it incredibly difficult to break!

‘How is he already this proficient with arrays?! He only learned the basics a few days ago! I have studied arrays under my father for over 20 years, yet I cannot defeat an array created by a complete newbie that learned arrays just a few days ago?! Impossible!’

“Father! Why are you just standing there? Hurry up and break this array so that we can help him!” Huang Xiao Li turned to her father for help, as she was confident that he had the ability to break the array.

However, Huang Chen remained standing there without moving a muscle, his gaze silently staring in the direction that Yuan went.

He closed his eyes and sighed, “The young man has already made his decision. I cannot go against it.”

“What?! That’s nonsense! He’s going to die if we leave him alone!”

“I’m sure he’s already prepared himself for that. Let’s not disrespect his resolution.”

He then looked at the array surrounding them and smiled, “I didn’t expect that he would also be an Array Master. He’s very good at it, too. Perhaps even better than you, Xiao Li. He must have trained very hard for many years to achieve this result.”

Huang Xiao Li frowned and said, “He only learned about arrays two days ago.”

“What did you just say?” Huang Chen turned to look at her with his eyes as wide as saucers.

“He didn’t even know about arrays until two days ago. That was also when I taught him the basics of arrays. And in that short amount of time, he’s managed to surpass me when it comes to low-level arrays.” She recalled.

“T-That’s absurd! How can someone become an Array Master from a complete beginner in just two short days? I don’t believe it!” Huang Chen exclaimed.

Huang Xiao Li shrugged and said, “You also wouldn’t believe what I witnessed in the room before we came here. Yuan... He’s a cultivation genius— monster...”

“That’s why I cannot bear to see him die. It would be a major loss to the cultivation world,” she sighed.

After a moment of silence, Huang Chen also sighed, “Even then, the young man has made a decision, and I will respect it.”

Meanwhile, a few hundred meters away from the ship, Yuan and about a hundred other cultivators anxiously waited for the Flying Leviathan to show up.

After waiting for a few minutes, they could finally see a figure in the distance that was quickly approaching them.

This figure started out as a small dot, but it grew very quickly until the cultivators could see very clearly what they were up against.

The Flying Leviathan's massive body was around 50 meters in diameter and hundreds of meters in length. Its long body was covered in blue scales that looked slightly green when shone by the sunlight.

However, its most distinctive feature was the massive wings on its back that created powerful waves with every flap.

The cultivators could feel themselves getting pushed back by the wind created by the Flying Leviathan despite being miles away.

ROOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOAR

The Flying Leviathan released a deafening roar filled with excitement when it saw the cultivators, sending shivers down their backs.

"Fuck! We're going to fight that monster?! There's no way we can defeat that!"

"Stay focused! We won't defeat it if you give up before the fight even starts!"

"If you give up without a fight, you'll definitely die! If you fight, there's still a chance that you'll survive!"

Many of the cultivators there have already lost their will to fight just by looking at the Flying Leviathan and feeling its immense aura that only got stronger as it got closer.

Yuan withdrew the Empyrean Overlord and the Starry Abyss and tried his best to clear his mind, but it wasn't easy with all of the screaming and loud noises there.

Once the Flying Leviathan was close enough, Yuan created a few more arrays that he'd learned from the book Huang Xiao Li had given him and applied them to himself.

These arrays boosted his defense, strength, and all of his other senses.

With the help of these arrays, his actual prowess rose to another level if not a few levels.

“The Flying Leviathan is here!”

The cultivators there began rushing at the Flying Leviathan when it got close enough, and all of them began using all of their treasures to suppress it.

However, the Flying Leviathan’s scales were incredibly durable, allowing it to defend and even deflect most of the cultivators’ attack.

As for Yuan’s attacks...

ROOOOOOOOOOOOAR

The Flying Leviathan suddenly released a painful cry when it felt something sharp pierce the scales it was very proud and confident in.

It immediately began looking for the cause of such pain, and it quickly spotted Yuan, who was near the end of its tail and swinging his large sword that was penetrating all of its defenses as though they didn’t exist.

Enraged, the Flying Leviathan ignored the other cultivators and began focusing on Yuan.

It suddenly opened its large mouth and spat out a jet stream of water that flew at Yuan like a bullet— a very large bullet that could easily collapse an entire skyscraper.

“Watch out!”

The cultivators there called out to Yuan, who immediately placed his sword in front of him to block it, as the ball of water was too large for him to dodge properly.

Chapter 684: Fighting the Flying Leviathan

Bang!

Yuan was sent flying after he tried to block the Flying Leviathan's attack.

"Fuck! He's a goner!" The cultivators there immediately thought Yuan had died from that attack and returned to fighting the Flying Leviathan without checking his condition.

After all, there was no way that a low-level Spirit Lord like him could survive a low-level Spirit Emperor's attack head-on and survive.

After flying for almost three miles from the impact, Yuan finally managed to stop himself.

"Whoa..." He released a sigh of relief when he realized that he was still alive.

In fact, besides feeling a little numb in his arms, he didn't really feel any pain from the attack just now.

"With the Invisible Dragon Cloak that doubles my defenses alongside my defensive arrays, I can survive even a Spirit Emperor's attack as long as I don't tank it with my bare body... Furthermore, I can injure the Flying Leviathan with my Sword Aura... I can do it! I can defeat this Flying Leviathan!"

A bright smile appeared on Yuan's face when he realized that he could win this fight, and he immediately began flying back to the battlefield.

However, he stopped moving when he suddenly thought of something.

‘Wait a moment... The Flying Leviathan should be occupied and distracted by the other cultivators right now. I can probably use this chance to deal some serious damage to the Flying Leviathan...’

Unfortunately, he was distracted by a powerful pressure before he could come up with a plan.

“What the?!”

A massive fish suddenly leaped out of the water and at Yuan with its mouth wide open.

He quickly reacted by controlling the Starry Abyss, boring a hole in the fish before it could reach him.

‘I was so distracted by the Flying Leviathan that I forgot other Sea Demons exist in this water...’ He sighed.

However, shortly after Yuan killed the Sea Demon, another random Sea Demon leaped out of the water to attack him.

“Just how many Sea Demons are there?!”

He decided to use his divine sense to look under the water, but he immediately regretted that action.

What he saw inside the water was true horror, where hundreds of powerful Sea Demons were swimming around, and he was only able to see about 50 meters deep due to some mysterious force that prevented him from looking any deeper than that.

After shivering away his fear, Yuan quickly flew higher towards the sky.

However, no matter how high he flew, the Sea Demons were somehow able to barely reach him just by leaping out of the water.

Yuan eventually gave up trying to linger around and continued flying back to the Flying Leviathan.

Once he could see the Flying Leviathan again, Yuan began gathering spiritual energy inside the Empyrean Overlord.

The Flying Leviathan that had been fighting the other cultivators suddenly stopped moving when it noticed the reappearance of Yuan's aura when he was about half a mile away from it, and it immediately began flying towards him again.

Seeing that the Flying Leviathan had noticed him, Yuan gathered as much spiritual energy as he could before releasing the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike at it.

The Flying Leviathan opened its mouth and shot out another water bullet at Yuan.

Bang!

The Heaven Splitting Sword Strike and the water bullet collided, creating a powerful blast that swept the place with spiritual energy, creating a massive wave that nearly consumed the cultivators there.

“Holy sh*t, he's still alive!”

“And he nearly killed us just now!”

“Hey! It appears that the young man can fight the Flying Leviathan by himself! If that's the case, there's no point for us to stay here! We'll only get caught up in their fight like we almost did just now!”

The cultivators there began flying back to the ship when they realized that Yuan was powerful enough to fight the Flying Leviathan by himself.

Of course, their decision was influenced by the Stairway to Heaven, as they weren't truly meant to fight the Flying Leviathan.

After all, this was Yuan's trial. The others are only there to set the atmosphere for him.

“What the?! They're leaving me alone to fight the Flying Leviathan by myself?!”

However, Yuan was left dumbfounded when he saw the cultivators returning to the ship, leaving him out here alone with a low-level Spirit Emperor Sea Demon.

Even though he knew he shouldn't blame them, it was still a bitter feeling to see them abandon him.

“Whatever! This is my trial! I shouldn't have expected any help in the first place!”

Yuan quickly cleared his mind and focused on the Flying Leviathan again.

“Come at me, you stupid flying snake! Let's get this over with so that I can move onto my next trial!” Yuan tightened his grip on the Emyrean Overlord before flying at the monster.

“Heavenly Domain!”

Yuan tried to use the Heavenly Domain on the Flying Leviathan, but its body was too big for it to be effective, so he quickly gave up on that and decided to just attack it until he defeated it.

Despite its large frame and threatening presence, the Flying Leviathan didn't have any crazy attacks that could threaten Yuan's life, and Yuan realized this after flying around for a few minutes to see if it had any special attacks that he hasn't seen yet.

Furthermore, because of its massive size, it was not very agile when attacking, allowing Yuan to easily dodge most of its attacks as long as he paid attention.

The only thing he really had to worry about was the water bullet, but even that attack is easily recognizable.

And for the next few minutes, Yuan would fly around the Flying Leviathan in a way that made it hard for the Flying Leviathan to attack him while sending his own attacks at it whenever he could.

In just a couple of minutes, the Flying Leviathan's body was covered in small and large wounds created by Yuan's sword and dagger.

The larger and deeper wounds were done by his sword that was strengthened by Sword Aura while the shallower wounds were created by the Starry Abyss.

Although his dagger didn't cause the Flying Leviathan as much pain as his sword, it actually created more wounds on its body due to its invisibility and the fact that it could be controlled by just Yuan's thoughts.

Eventually, the Flying Leviathan began slowing down due to losing too much blood.

Yuan took advantage of this by becoming more aggressive towards it.

Half an hour later, the Flying Leviathan's movements had slowed down by so much that Yuan could no longer feel any threat from it.

However, he didn't let his guard down and continued to wear down the Flying Leviathan until it was on the verge of death.

The Flying Leviathan eventually realized the fact that it was slowly being defeated by a human cultivator that was two realms below it, and it released its loudest roar yet.

Yuan prepared himself for the unknown, but to his surprise, the Flying Leviathan began moving towards the water.

"It wants to escape?!"

He immediately began chasing after it.

He didn't want the Flying Leviathan to return for revenge after it recovered its strength, so he has to defeat it now.

Yuan's body suddenly erupted with a domineering aura that was so sharp that it split the water around him.

“Vanishing Ghost's Soundless Blade!”

A powerful sword light flew towards the escaping Flying Leviathan without making even the slightest noise until it reached the Flying Leviathan, slicing its steel-like scales as though it was butter before cutting into its skin and meat.

Sha!

The Flying Leviathan was cut in half, but the sword strike didn't stop and continued until it reached the water, also splitting the sea in half.

The people watching from the ship were shocked speechless after witnessing the whole act.

They have never seen someone single-handedly defeat a Flying Leviathan before, much less force it to run for its life.

From the beginning to end, Yuan was pretty much bullying the Flying Leviathan to its slow but inevitable death.

Yuan did not immediately celebrate his victory and silently watched the Flying Leviathan's body sink deeper and deeper into the sea until he could no longer see it with his divine sense.

There was also a large area of the sea that had turned red due to the Flying Leviathan's blood.

Once he was certain that the Flying Leviathan would not return, Yuan closed his eyes and released a sigh of relief before making his way back to the ship.

Chapter 685: Stairway to Heaven's Third Trial

After killing the Flying Leviathan, Yuan returned to the ship, but it was completely silent upon his arrival.

There was no celebration, and everybody there merely stared at him with dazed looks. Some of them even had a hint of fear within their gaze.

In their eyes, someone who could defeat the Flying Leviathan that they find terrifying is obviously even more terrifying, and their minds could not help but transfer their fear for the Flying Leviathan to Yuan.

“Thank you for letting me protect you all.” Yuan removed the array that confined the Huang Family and the bodyguards.

He knew very well that Huang Chen could've broken the array very easily, but Huang Chen didn't do that and instead allowed him to protect them.

Huang Chen casually snorted, “You're not done protecting us just yet. We still have to arrive at the Giant's Continent.”

Huang Xiao Li suddenly stepped forward and swung her arm, giving Yuan a loud and crisp slap on the face.

“I can't believe you left me behind like that.”

However, before Yuan could even react, she opened her arms and gave him a tight embrace.

“I'm a little tired so I will return to the room now.” She then said.

Yuan nodded, “I will protect you while you rest.”

Everyone there eventually returned to their rooms with nobody really leaving their rooms afterward.

Sea Demons still attacked the ship, but that wasn’t a problem for the ship since most of the guards had survived the Flying Leviathan’s attack, allowing them to continue protecting the ship.

The Raging Serpent encountered three more large-size Sea Demons before they arrived at the Giant’s Continent two days later, but compared to the Flying Leviathan, they were easily taken care of.

“We have arrived at the Giant’s Continent! The Raging Serpent will remain docked here for 14 days before we must return home. Please finish your business and return here by then, or you will have to wait for the next ship.”

As the ship approached the land of Giant’s Continent, Yuan received a notification.

[You have successfully escorted the Huang Family to the Giant’s Continent without any casualties]

After the notification disappeared, the door behind Yuan opened, and the Huang Family came out of their room.

“Yuan, here is your reward for your contributions— for protecting my family.” Huang Xiao Li extended her hands that were holding an opened box to him.

Sitting inside this box was a glowing orb of light that gave Yuan a nostalgic feeling.

‘It’s my memories...’ He thought to himself.

And without needing him to move a muscle, the glowing orb of light flew out of the box and into Yuan’s forehead.

Memories immediately began flowing inside his head, but he didn't have the time to see them.

"Thank you." He said to them afterward.

The Huang Family didn't say anything and merely smiled at him.

When Yuan blinked his eyes a second later, the Huang Family and the ship had disappeared.

He looked around, and sure enough, he had returned to the Stairway to Heaven.

"That's the end of the second trial? Why does it feel incomplete? I wanted to see some giants, too." Yuan said out loud.

He was expecting to escort the Huang Family until they traded their treasures with the giants before completing the second trial, but that didn't seem to be the case.

Tian'er's voice then resounded, "I have no control over your trial. That is for the Stairway to Heaven to decide."

Yuan sighed at her words.

"Alright. Take me to the next trial."

"You have one hour to rest. Do you wish to continue without resting?"

He nodded, "I had plenty of rest during the end of the trial."

Although he could still cultivate the spiritual energy in the Stairway to Heaven, it would no longer benefit his cultivation as much as before now that he's a Spirit Lord.

Therefore, he decided to just head on to the third trial.

Another set of stairs appeared at the end of the stage for him to climb.

After taking a deep breath, he began climbing the staircase.

“What do you think his next trial will be?” Min Li asked the others in the spectators’ room.

“Well, the Stairway to Heaven isn’t all about fighting, and he’s already had to fight two incredibly powerful opponents. His third trial might be entirely different.” Feng Yuxiang said.

Many minutes later, Yuan arrived at the third floor.

“For your third trial, you must prevent the mortals from being squashed into meat paste.” Tian’er’s voice resounded.

“Huh?” Yuan raised his eyebrows, as he was unable to comprehend the trial at first.

The scenery began to change, and Yuan found himself standing on an invisible platform about 100 meters off the ground.

It looked like he was in the middle of an ordinary village, but when he looked down, he could see a bunch of people kneeling on the ground and cowering in fear.

Amongst this group were the elderly, young men and women, and even children. In fact, half of these people were children. However, they were all kneeling on the ground with their hands covering their head, almost like they were afraid of something falling on their heads.

“What kind of trial is this?” Yuan couldn’t help but mumble to himself

Suddenly, a notification appeared.

[You have started your third trial in the Stairway to Heaven!]

[You must protect the mortals from being squashed for 12 hours!]

[Protect them for 24 hours to receive a reward!]

Right as the notification disappeared, a large shadow suddenly enveloped Yuan and the mortals below, causing him to look up, and to his absolute shock, there appeared to be a massive temple that was made out of pure gold falling from the sky.

Yuan's immediate response was to dodge this falling temple, but then he recalled the people below him and the trial.

It was at this moment that he realized the true nature of this trial.

'If I dodge this falling temple, the people below me will die, and I will fail the trial!' He cried inwardly.

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Chapter 686: Golden Temple

After realizing what he has to do, Yuan quickly retrieves the Empyrean Overlord before releasing the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike at the falling temple.

The Heaven Splitting Sword Strike collided with the base of the golden temple in the air, but the temple completely shrugged off the attack as though it was nothing.

Yuan's eyes widened with shock when there wasn't even a single scratch on the temple despite being struck by his most powerful attack.

However, he didn't give up and tried it again, resulting in the same conclusion.

"The temple is indestructible, Master." Tian'er's voice suddenly resounded.

"How am I supposed to protect those people at the bottom if I cannot destroy that temple?!" He cried out loud.

"You must use— sacrifice your body to protect the mortals."

"U-Use my body...?" Yuan swallowed nervously when he realized what Tian'er wanted him to do.

"Why is he just standing there?! He'll get squashed by the temple if he doesn't do anything!" Min Li exclaimed in a worried voice.

"Maybe it's because that is his trial." Feng Yuxiang said.

"A common trial in the Stairway to Heaven is endurance, which normally requires the challenger to endure a powerful pressure for a certain amount

of time. In the Young Master's case, that golden temple is the 'pressure'," she explained.

"That golden temple looks really heavy, though... Is it even possible to endure that?" Chu Liuxiang asked.

"The Young Master has no choice but to endure it, or he will fail the trial..."

Once the golden temple arrived on top of Yuan, he decided to use his body to catch it.

Dong!

Yuan could feel his entire body being pressed towards the ground, and every bone in his muscle was screaming in pain, especially his legs, which were shaking as though there was an earthquake.

"Aaaaah!"

Yuan released a painful scream after catching the golden temple that weighed tens of thousands of tons.

And in just a few moments, Yuan was forced to kneel on the invisible platform.

"Master..."

Tian'er was surprised when she saw Yuan catching the golden temple with nothing but his raw body.

This trial was designed to limit test a cultivator's spiritual energy. In other words, Yuan was supposed to cover his body in spiritual energy before catching the temple.

However, Yuan had caught the temple without using his spiritual energy, meaning that he'd caught it with his raw strength, which was an amazing feat considering that the temple could easily crush even a peak Spirit King with ease if they didn't use spiritual energy.

“Master, use your spiritual energy. You will never survive this trial like that.” Tian’er decided to point him in the right direction even though she wasn’t really supposed to do that.

After hearing her words, Yuan promptly activated the spiritual energy in his Dantian.

Spiritual energy quickly began flowing through every vein in Yuan’s body, boosting his strength immensely.

Once his entire body was covered in spiritual energy, Yuan immediately felt the weight on his body lessen by a large amount, allowing him to breathe properly.

After catching his breath and getting comfortable with having a huge temple on his back, Yuan stood back up and proceeded to focus on his spiritual energy.

If he doesn’t circulate his spiritual energy wisely, he will run out of spiritual energy before the trial ends, which would be disastrous for him.

Therefore, he must use just enough spiritual energy to make carrying the temple barely endurable for him.

‘I will have to stay like this for 24 hours? I should have taken that one hour break when I had the chance!’ Yuan sighed inwardly, regretting his decision to give up his one hour of peace.

If he knew what he was walking into, he would’ve definitely taken that break to prepare himself.

Not only is the third trial the most tedious trial thus far, it was also the most boring. After all, he could only stand still and do nothing but carry this immensely heavy temple.

About two hours later, Yuan adapted to his situation and could control the flow of his spiritual energy as easily as breathing, allowing him to focus less on himself and more on other things, such as his memories.

He looked at the time.

[Time: 2:10:12]

[Time: 2:10:13]

[Time: 2:10:14]

“It’s only been two hours? I swear it feels much longer than that...” He sighed.

He closed his eyes a moment later and began delving into his memories.

Meanwhile, in the spectators’ room.

“Meixiu, do you have any knowledge on Greek mythology?” Chu Liuxiang suddenly asked her.

“Not really,” she said.

“Well, Yuan’s situation reminds me of a very famous mythology about a titan that was condemned to hold up the heavens for eternity.”

“Holding the heavens... You mean Atlas?” Meixiu remembered hearing about it in school before.

“So you do have some knowledge. That’s right. However, he wasn’t doing it for righteousness or anything like that. He was doing it as a punishment.”

“And seeing Yuan like that... It makes me wonder if he’s being punished.”

Meixiu lifted her brows in a questioning manner, “Why would he be punished? This is just a trial.”

“I know, but I cannot help but have the feeling that the Stairway to Heaven is punishing him. This might even be the hardest trial yet.” Chu Liuxiang sighed.

“How long does he have to carry that golden temple? He’s already been at it for 2 hours.” Min Li suddenly asked.

“It varies from person to person.” Feng Yuxiang said.

Meanwhile, Yuan recalled his memories as an outer court disciple at Immortal’s Monastery.

For every hour he spends in real-time, he has experienced many months, even years in his memories.

And after watching his memories for some time, Yuan eventually came to the conclusion that his previous life as Tian Yang had an ordinary if not less-than-ordinary life as a cultivator.

He was neither talented nor hopeless. He was just an ordinary cultivator that one could find anywhere in the cultivation world.

However, this only made Yuan more puzzled, as the Tian Yang inside his dreams was incredibly powerful.

How did someone who started out so ordinary become so extraordinary? Yuan’s anticipation grew the more he recalled his memories.

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Chapter 687: Hunting Grounds

“I have been an outer court disciple for an entire year now, yet I am still a fourth level Spirit Apprentice. At this rate, it will take another 3 years before I reach Spirit Warrior...” Tian Yang sighed as he sat inside his living quarters within the outer court of the Immortal Monastery.

“I thought that by becoming an official disciple, I would receive the sect’s support by receiving plentiful resources to help my cultivation, but alas, how naive was I back then to believe such a thing...”

“As an outer court disciple, I am given a single spirit stone every three months to assist with my cultivation, but that spirit stone will only last us about a week if we cultivate sparingly. In order to acquire more resources, we must go into the hunting grounds or become an inner court disciple.”

“However, I must enter the Spirit Master realm in order to apply for the inner court examination, and who knows how many years that will take me...”

“If I want to grow stronger, I must enter the hunting grounds and find my own resources.”

With that in mind, Tian Yang decided to enter the hunting grounds for the first time since he became an outer court disciple.

The hunting grounds is a special area within the sect’s territory where disciples go to hunt magical beasts and acquire treasures.

Of course, all of this is within the sect’s control, meaning that every magical beast and treasure found inside the hunting ground was put there by the sect to help their disciples.

However, while the territory is under the sect's control, that didn't mean it wasn't a dangerous place.

In fact, disciples can still lose their lives there, and it happens quite often.

And with a single sword in hand, Tian Yang left his living quarters to enter the hunting grounds.

"I would like to enter the hunting grounds." Tian Yang said to the sect elder sitting outside the entrance.

The sect elder glanced at him before scoffing, "You're only a fourth level Spirit Apprentice. Even the weakest magical beasts inside are at the fifth level. Although there are sect elders inside to keep the casualties as low as possible, there is still a good chance that you could die. Do you still want to enter?"

"I still want to enter." Tian Yang nodded with a serious face.

"Show me your disciple identification badge."

After handing the sect elder his badge, the sect elder recorded his name, badge number, and the day he entered the hunting grounds into the log book. This way, they will know that he died inside the hunting grounds if he doesn't return.

"You may enter the hunting grounds. If you don't return within three days, the sect will consider you dead." The sect elder said to him.

"Thank you, sect elder."

Tian Yang didn't say anything else and entered the hunting grounds with an ordinary sword already in his grasp.

Once he was inside the hunting grounds, Tian Yang moved with caution, and his eyes would continuously look around with wariness.

Although he has hunted animals before, he has never encountered a magical beast, so he was very nervous.

After walking around for about half an hour, Tian Yang encountered his first magical beast.

It had the appearance of a wolf, and it was emitting a powerful aura at the fifth level Spirit Apprentice.

Tian Yang swallowed his nervousness and slowly approached the magical beast.

The magical beast noticed the killing intent in Tian Yang's eyes, so it pounced at him in retaliation.

“Ha!”

Tian Yang subconsciously swung his sword at the magical beast, and the magical beast swung its powerful paws in return.

Clang!

The sword flew right out of Tian Yang's grasp and landed many meters away when he underestimated the magical beast's strength.

“Oh, fuck...”

Tian Yang realized that without his sword, he was pretty much defenseless in front of the magical beast.

He could turn around and run away, but something inside his heart told him to stay and fight the magical beast, and that's exactly what he did.

However, because of his reckless decision, Tian Yang ended up lying on the floor with blood all over his clothes, and they were his own blood.

“Why didn't you run away when you lost your sword?” A calm voice resounded beside him.

Tian Yang turned his head to look at the beautiful woman standing beside him.

She was wearing the sect elder's uniform, and she was also the one who saved his life when he was about to be killed by the magical beast.

"I... don't know..." He responded in a low voice while staring at the sect elder's confused face.

"What you did today was very reckless. Don't do it again if you value your life." The sect elder said to him before taking out a medicine pill and stuffing it inside his mouth.

"Go home. You're not ready for this place yet." She said to him.

Tian Yang silently nodded his head and returned home when he could walk again.

However, three days later, after recovering from his injuries, Tian Yang returned to the hunting grounds.

And once again, he was nearly killed by a magical beast before being saved by a sect elder.

"Thank you for saving me again, elder."

The sect elder's eyes widened with surprise after recognizing him.

"You... Why are you here again? I thought I told you that you aren't ready for the hunting grounds," said the sect elder who happened to be the same person who saved him three days ago.

"That's why I returned, and I will continue coming here until I am ready or I am dead," he said in a calm voice.

"You're not afraid of dying?"

"No, I don't fear death. I only fear being powerless in a world where the strong rule the weak."

The sect elder became speechless after hearing his words.

“You’re reckless... and crazy.” She left him alone after saying those words, but for some reason, she continued to watch over him from a distance.

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Chapter 688: Hunting Grounds(2)

Another year has passed since Yuan— Tian Yang became an outer court disciple in the Immortal Monastery, and he has been going to the hunting grounds almost every single day without fail.

Only during the days that he's too injured to move and the days that he has to cultivate that he doesn't enter the hunting grounds.

However, despite his recklessness, he has managed to survive up to this point, and his cultivation saw a significant boost, reaching the ninth level Spirit Apprentice only a year later.

“Good morning, Elder Lee.” Tian Yang greeted the sect elder sitting outside the hunting grounds.

“Try not to die again today.” Elder Lee said to him, not even bothering to write his name down in the log book.

Even if Tian Yang dies inside the hunting grounds, Elder Lee has already memorized Tian Yang's face and voice after seeing him so often, so he could tell if something had happened to Tian Yang if he doesn't show up after a few days.

After entering the hunting grounds, Tian Yang went deeper into the place without hesitation, and if he encountered a magical beast, he would always fight it, regardless of its cultivation.

“Nice. First kill of the day and I already have a monster core.” Tian Yang picked up the crystal after killing the magical beast with a single strike.

“Aaaaah! Somebody, help!”

Tian Yang suddenly heard screaming, and the sound didn't seem very far away.

Without thinking, he immediately began running towards the screaming.

A minute later, he arrived before two disciples, one male and one female, and a magical beast.

However, one of these disciplines—the male disciple was lying on the ground with a puddle of blood beneath him.

As for the female disciple, she was standing a couple of meters away, trying her best to defend against the magical beast.

Tian Yang didn't hesitate to jump into the battle after seeing the situation.

A few minutes later, Tian Yang gasped for air as he stared at the dead magical beast before him.

“Are you okay...?” He turned to ask the female disciple, who was shaking in fear not far away from him.

She nodded in a dazed manner, “I-I am fine... B-But what about him? Is he dead?”

Tian Yang approached the disciple and checked for his pulses, but there was nothing.

He shook his head, “He's dead.”

The female disciple immediately began crying.

“Go home, and tell the elder outside about what happened. I will escort you outside.” Tian Yang said to the disciple a moment later.

The female disciple nodded, and Tian Yang made sure that she left the hunting grounds safely before returning back to the depths of the hunting grounds, where magical beasts around his level roamed.

After spending an entire day at the hunting grounds, Tian Yang went to a specific area there and shouted, “Elder Sun! Are you there?!”

A figure answered his call and appeared before him a few moments later.

“What do you want? Did you miss me since we haven’t seen each other for two months now?”

Elder Sun was the sect elder who had saved his life on his first day in the hunting ground— as well as many more times in the future.

She had gotten so used to saving his life that it almost became her job to watch Tian Yang while he’s inside the hunting grounds, almost like an exclusive guard for Tian Yang.

However, it was not as though she was obligated to protect him. She just couldn’t help but watch over him like a guardian of sorts.

Elder Sun had gotten so used to seeing his face that she could see him very clearly even with her eyes closed, almost as though Tian Yang’s appearance was imprinted in her mind.

“I won’t lie, I do miss you a little, especially since I am no longer training in your area, where I don’t have to worry about losing my life. However, that’s not why I called you here today.”

“This may seem very random and out of the blue, but I was hoping if you could find a disciple for me. Her name is Meng Lili, and we joined the sect together, but I haven’t seen her for two years, nor have I been able to find her, and I have asked many people.”

Elder Sun frowned upon hearing his request, and she spoke, “You called me here... in the middle of the night... just to ask about another woman? I feel sorry for your future dao companion.”

“Or is this Meng Lili your girlfriend?”

“No, we’re nothing of that sort. She’s just a friend that came from the same background.”

“Then why do you care about her?”

“I want to see how she’s doing in the sect. It’s just pure curiosity,” he replied with a calm face.

Elder Sun narrowed her eyes at him.

After a moment of silence, she spoke, “What do I get out of this? I may have saved your life multiple times in the past, but that is my job. Looking for your girlfriend isn’t my job.”

“Like I’d already said, she’s not my girlfriend... And what do you want from me? If it’s money you want, I am afraid that is not possible since I am completely broke.”

“I don’t need your money,” she quickly said.

“Then what do you want? As long as it’s reasonable.”

She lifted her hand and pointed a finger at him.

Tian Yang raised his eyebrows, as he was unable to comprehend her actions.

“I want your body in exchange for this information,” she said, making things clear for him.

“M-My body?” Tian Yang took a step back from shock.

“B-But you’re a sect elder and I am a disciple... You’re no doubt a very beautiful woman that can have any men that you set your eyes on, but I don’t think we should... Actually, if we keep it a secret, perhaps we can...”

Pap!

Elder Sun suddenly slapped him in the back of the head and exclaimed with a flushed face, “Who said I want your body for that kind of stuff?! I want your body for labor! You’re going to help me with something! As if I’d have that kind of thoughts for an outer court disciple!”

Even though it was quite dark, Tian Yang could still see the redness on her face.

“Oh... but if you ever have such thoughts, I wouldn't mind...” Tian Yang said with a shameless smile on his face.

“Shut your mouth before I feed you a magical beast!” She slapped him again.

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Chapter 689: Hunting Grounds(3)

“Fine, if you can help me, my body will be yours.” Tian Yang said to Elder Sun.

Elder Sun nodded, “It’s a promise. Come here at the same time a week from now.”

“Okay.”

Tian Yang left the hunting grounds and returned to his living quarters to spend the next week absorbing the monster cores that he’d acquired from the magical beasts within the hunting grounds.

Even though he killed at least a dozen magical beasts every week for the last year, he would only get a single monster core for every 10 magical beasts he killed, and that’s if he was lucky, so it was not as if he has a lot of monster cores to support his cultivation base.

Furthermore, cultivating with monster cores isn’t very healthy for cultivators due to how much impurities monster cores contain.

However, unlike Yuan, Tian Yang did not have the ability to swallow monster cores and instantly absorb all of its spiritual energies, so it would take him at least a week to finish absorbing a monster core.

A week later, Tian Yang left his living quarters and made his way towards the hunting grounds.

After arriving at the area that Elder Sun oversees, he waited for her to show up.

About ten minutes later, Tian Yang felt a presence suddenly appear behind him.

He turned around to see Elder Sun standing there, but she had a solemn expression on her face.

“It’s been a long time since I saw you with such a serious face.” Tian Yang said when he saw her face that was basked in moonlight, making her look more beautiful than usual, especially her eyes that glistened like a clear lake.

“I have asked around about your girlfriend, Meng Lili.” Elder Sun said.

“Oh? Let’s hear it. Has she become an inner court disciple by now? Maybe she was even accepted by a powerful master within the sect. Given her talents, I doubt she will be anything other than extraordinary—.”

Before Tian Yang could even finish his sentence, Elder Sun interrupted him, “She’s dead.”

“W-What?” Tian Yang’s eyes widened with shock.

“What did you just say? That she’s dead? How is that possible?”

Elder Sun sighed, “This Meng Lili was accepted as an outer court disciple about five years ago after spending 6 months in the Bamboo Garden, am I correct? Or did I investigate the wrong person?”

“No... It sounds about right...” Tian Yang recalled very clearly that Meng Lili had become the first person to leave the Bamboo Garden, becoming an outer court disciple in just half a year.

“B-But that doesn’t make sense... How can someone so talented die? How did she even die? When did she die?”

“She died shortly after becoming an outer court disciple. As for her cause of death... she was most likely murdered by someone according to the evidences. Another disciple had found her body in the outer court, and she was already deceased by then.”

“Shortly after she became an outer court disciple? Is that why nobody seemed to know her? I thought it was weird that someone talented like Meng Lili would be a nobody...”

“You have my condolences...” Elder Sun sighed.

“Does the sect know who killed her? Did they investigate her death?” Tian Yang asked after a moment of silence.

“No, the sect did not investigate the incident. She was only an outer court disciple, and it’s common for disciples to die in the sect due to our competitive nature.”

“Is that so...”

Tian Yang looked at the moon and stood there in silence for many moments.

He then looked at Elder Sun with a painful expression, “Thank you for everything, Elder Sun. As promised, you can do whatever you want with my body, but give me a few days to clear my head. I won’t be able to focus on whatever you task me with in my current state.”

Seeing Tian Yang’s expression, Elder Sun also felt a prickling sensation in her heart. She suddenly extended her arms and embraced him.

“Take all the time you need, Disciple Tian...”

Although she couldn’t hear any noises coming from Tian Yang, she could feel her shoulders getting wet, presumably from Tian Yang’s tears.

Tian Yang returned to his room shortly after, where he would spend the next couple of days contemplating Meng Lili’s mysterious death.

“When one dies, are they considered powerless because they cannot do anything, or are they invincible because they are no longer bound by the laws of this cruel world, nor do they have to worry about being weak?”

“It appears that my goal to surpass you has already been met without my awareness, and when one achieves their goal, they will find another one.

Therefore, my next goal will be to find the truth behind your death and deal with it accordingly.”

“...”

“Why is Brother Yuan suddenly crying?” Xiao Hua mumbled in a low voice when she noticed the tears on Yuan’s face.

“I would be crying too if I was in his shoes right now,” said Chu Liuxiang.

“How long has it been since the trial started?” Min Li asked.

“It’s been almost an entire day,” said Feng Yuxiang.

“Do you think it’ll end soon?”

Feng Yuxiang shrugged.

Inside the trial, Yuan slowly opened his eyes after he finished looking through his memories, and the first thing he did was look at the timer.

[23:14:20]

[23:14:21]

[23:14:22]

‘Less than an hour left...’ He sighed inwardly.

He then looked up at the golden temple that he had been carrying this entire time.

‘If it were not for my breakthrough to Spirit Lord, I probably wouldn’t have survived 24 hours in this trial...’

This made Yuan wonder what would happen if he didn’t finish the bonus challenge and receive his reward. Would he lose the chance to regain a part of his memories forever? Or would it simply delay his process?

Whatever is supposed to happen, he doesn't intend on finding out.

Forty-five minutes later, Yuan has successfully endured 24 hours of this gruesome trial, putting an end to the third trial.

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Chapter 690: Stairway to Heaven's Fourth Trial

Ding!

[You have successfully protected the mortals for 24 hours]

After receiving this notification, Yuan felt the weight on his body disappear, causing him to look up.

The golden temple that had suddenly disappeared, replaced by a glowing orb of light that slowly approached Yuan's forehead.

Yuan didn't reject the light and allowed it to enter him, and more memories began flowing inside his mind like a gush of water at a broken dam.

However, he didn't have the time to indulge in these memories, as the scenery had changed back to its original background.

"Congratulations on passing your third trial, Master. You have an hour to rest before we start the next trial. Do you wish to rest or continue?"
Tian'er's calm voice resounded after the trial ended.

"Yes, I want to rest. I will need all the time I can get after that trial..." Yuan immediately sat down and began cultivating with his body still soaked in sweat.

While he cultivated, a gentle breeze would blow around Yuan, magically cleaning his sweat from his body and his clothes.

An hour later, Yuan stood up and began making his way towards the next trial.

“Welcome to your fourth and final trial, Master.”

“Did I just hear ‘final’ trial?” Yuan asked for confirmation.

“That’s correct. If you pass this one, you will get to ascend to the next realm.” Tian’er responded.

“Then what are you waiting for? Let’s get this trial started!”

The scenery changed a moment later.

Yuan looked around after the scenery finished changing, and he appeared to be in some sort of empty field.

However, this empty field felt very familiar for some reason, almost as though he’d been there before.

“That place is...”

Inside the spectators’ room, both Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang covered their mouth in shock when they saw the scenery, especially when they saw the building standing right behind Yuan.

“What is my trial this time?” Yuan asked as he looked around.

It was at this moment he realized that there was a building behind him, but his face and body froze like a stone statue when he saw this building— this temple.

“This place is... impossible...”

He stared at the temple in a daze.

The temple he was staring at resembled the Six Spiritual Families’ Ancestor’ Tomb in the Jaded Garden. No, it was exactly the same.

“For the fourth trial, you will need to defeat ‘your’ demon, Master.”

Ding!

[You have started your fourth trial in the Stairway to Heaven!]

[You must defeat the demon within your body!]

[Pass the fourth trial to receive a reward!]

“I have to defeat a demon for this trial...?” Yuan frowned, feeling obnoxious about the situation.

“Aaaaaaah! Help! Yuan! Help me!”

A voice that Yuan immediately recognized suddenly resounded, and his body trembled when he heard it.

“Azure?!”

And without hesitation, he began running towards the voice.

He ran and ran... Just like when he was chasing after the demon at the Jaded Garden.

As he traveled, Yuan noticed the buildings and sceneries there resembled the Jaded Garden.

“No... This is the Jaded Garden! But how?! Did the Stairway to Heaven take this place out of my memories just for this trial?!”

After running for about half an hour, Yuan arrived at the Immortal Caves, feeling as though he was reenacting his past.

And sure enough, when he arrived at the scene, he could see a red-skinned human figure standing right in front of a beautiful young lady who had her eyes closed.

However, this beautiful young lady looked very pale, and there was a hole in her chest.

“Yuan... Are you there...? My body feels cold... Help me...”

The demon turned to look at Yuan and smiled, “Once again, you have failed to protect her.”

Hearing the demon’s mockery, Yuan immediately erupted with anger and killing intent.

“I did not have the power to personally deal with you before, but things are different now!” Yuan withdrew the Emyrean Overlord and rushed at the demon.

Whoosh!

Yuan quickly defeated the demon in a single strike— with the Demon Sealing Strike. It had ended so quickly that even Yuan was surprised by how easy it was to defeat the demon.

“Different? There’s nothing different about this. You managed to kill me, so what? Your little girlfriend is still dead. It’s the same as last time— exactly the same. Hahaha!” The demon laughed as its body disintegrated until nothing of it was left.

Yuan turned his focus onto Azure after killing the demon, but her body was nowhere to be seen.

“Azure?”

Yuan blinked his eyes in a dazed manner. However, when he reopened his eyes, his scenery had changed.

He was no longer in the Immortal Caves. Instead, he had returned to the empty field right outside the Ancestors’ Tomb.

“W-What happened? Why am I—”

“Aaaaah! Yuan! Please help me! There’s a demon here!”

Before he could collect his thoughts, Yuan heard Azure’s voice screaming for his help, and once again, he began running towards the voice, returning to the Immortal Caves half an hour later.

And sure enough, the demon was there, as well as Azure, who had a hole in her chest.

“Yuan... You broke your promise to me again for the third time...” Azure mumbled those words before collapsing onto the ground.

“Aaaaah!”

Yuan released his anger out on the demon, killing it a moment later.

However, after defeating the demon, Yuan found himself back at the Ancestors’ Tomb, almost as though he’d traveled back in time, repeating his most traumatic event over and over again.

And no matter how many times he was sent back to the Ancestors’ Tomb, Yuan would return to the Immortal Caves to witness the demon killing Azure.

Ten... twenty... fifty times...

Yuan had lost count of how many times he’d repeated this tragedy, but he did not stop, and he continued to return to the Immortal Caves, hoping that he’d be able to save her in time even once.

Unfortunately, the Stairway to Heaven did not grant him that wish, and it continued to torture Yuan’s soul in an never-ending cycle where he’s forced to watch Azure die by the demon’s hands while he was only a few moments away from being able to save her.

Chapter 691: Yuan's Heart Demon

“What kind of trial is this?” Meixiu mumbled in a dazed voice as she watched Yuan defeat the demon multiple times.

“By the looks of it, this trial appears to be some sort of heart demon trial.” Feng Yuxiang said.

“What is that?”

“In essence, heart demons are stress— a negative emotion that looms in the deepest part of one's heart. When someone experiences a traumatic event or something terrifying, there is a very high chance that whatever happened becomes their heart demon, and these negative emotions become a mental barrier which hinders their cultivation from advancing.”

“Heart demons are very common, and they exist in almost everyone, including mortals, but they affect cultivators the most. Heart demons can be formed by any kind of stress if it's strong enough. Fearing that you'll never find love... Being insecure about your appearances... Worrying about not being able to return your debt... Even one's obsessions can also become one's heart demon.”

“As for the Young Master's trial... He will most likely have to defeat his heart demon in order to pass this trial.” Feng Yuxiang sighed.

“So... Basically anything emotional can become a heart demon? How does one even defeat their heart demon?” Chu Liuxiang asked.

“It depends on their heart demon. If someone is insecure about their appearances, they need to stop being insecure. If one fears they cannot find love, they must stop fearing. In the Young Master's case... He must stop blaming himself for the death of that young lady.”

“That... sounds easier said than done.” Chu Liuxiang shook her head.

“Of course. It’s not easy to defeat one’s heart demon, and even powerful Immortals that can change another’s fate can fall victim to their own heart demon. Furthermore, even if one manages to defeat their current heart demon, another one could show up in the future when they experience something emotional again. This is something all cultivators must confront at one point in their lives, and they either succumb to their heart demon or they defeat it.” Feng Yuxiang sighed.

Meanwhile, Yuan continued to repeat his nightmares.

“Damn it! Why hasn’t the trial ended already?! I have defeated the demon countless times by now!” Yuan cried out loud after being sent back to the Ancestors’ Tomb.

Clearly, he’s misunderstanding the true nature and purpose of the trial, thinking that his trial was to defeat the demon, unaware that it was actually mentioning another demon—the one dwelling inside his heart.

Thus, for the next few hours, he would repeat the same scenario over and over again, falling deeper into this rabbit hole that’s his demon heart until he could no longer move.

“Haaaa... haaa... haaaa...”

Yuan collapsed onto the ground after killing the demon and returning to the Ancestors’ Tomb countless times.

“Why...? What kind of trial is this...?”

He looked at the trial requirements again.

[You must defeat the demon within your body to pass the fourth trial!]

“The demon within my body... If it’s not talking about the demon that I have been slaying, what else is it talking about? Is there another demon in this place?”

“You’re still hung up on that woman’s death?”

A voice suddenly resounded inside Yuan’s head, but it was not Tian’er’s voice.

“You need to stop blaming yourself for what happened to Azure.” Tian Yang’s voice resounded.

“But it’s the truth. If I had defeated the demon before it escaped the Ancestors’ Tomb, Azure would have never died.”

“Yes... but that’s not what happened. You can speculate all you want, but what’s happened has happened. You cannot go back in time to fix your mistakes— only forward.”

“If it was a mistake, then it’s obviously my fault.” Yuan sighed.

“Or maybe it was her fate to die there. If that was the case, she would have died regardless of what you did...”

“That’s nonsense...”

“Is it really, though?” Tian Yang chuckled.

“Do you believe it’s a coincidence that you’re in your position? Perhaps fate brought you there.”

“If fate brought me here, I will deny it— I will alter my own fate.”

“Fate cannot be easily denied. It requires tremendous power— power that you do not possess right now.”

“Then help me achieve that power. We’re the same person, right?”

After a moment of silence, Tian Yang’s figure appeared before Yuan like a ghost.

He pointed at Yuan with a profound smile on his face.

“What did you think I have been doing for the past millenniums— past eons? I have been trying to acquire that power ever since the dawn of time — even before the first known era that you all call ‘Primordial Era’...”

“You... We already have that power— the power to deny our fate. You just need to awaken that power.”

“How... How do I do that?”

Tian Yang looked at the direction of the Immortal Caves and said, “You can start by passing this trial.”

After saying those words, Tian Yang’s figure disappeared.

“Is he talking to himself? Has he gone crazy from this trial?” Chu Liuxiang asked with a worried face after seeing Yuan speaking to the empty air there, as she was unable to see Tian Yang through the pond.

“Dealing with one’s heart demon can indeed make someone go crazy, but I don’t think that’s what happened to the Young Master.” Feng Yuxiang shook her head.

“Look! He’s moving again!” Min Li suddenly pointed at the pond.

Chu Liuxiang immediately turned to look, and sure enough, Yuan was running towards the Immortal Caves again, but there was something different about him this time.

“His face... It’s filled with resolve...” Meixiu mumbled to herself after seeing the expression on Yuan’s face.

Half an hour later, Yuan arrived at the Immortal Caves, right when the demon struck Azure in the chest with its sharp claws.

However, Yuan didn’t immediately rush at the demon to release his anger this time.

He merely stood there in silence, staring at Azure’s bloodied body with a profound gaze, his thoughts unknown to the spectators.

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Chapter 692: Leaving the Lower Heavens

“Once again, you’re late to the party, killing her.” The demon looked at Yuan with a smirk on its face.

Yuan closed his eyes and took a deep breath before releasing it slowly.

“You’re right. I killed her by being too slow. She died because I was too weak.”

He opened his eyes, and the demon was no longer there. Instead, Yuan could see himself standing where the demon stood, almost as though the demon had transformed into his appearance.

“Finally, you’re accepting the fact that you’re responsible for her death.” The demon’s voice resounded while wearing his appearance.

“That’s not right. I have accepted the fact that I couldn’t protect her even before I left the Jaded Garden. I blamed myself for her death, and I still do.”

“I just didn’t want to deal with the guilt of killing her, and I even tried to forget about it. However, I now know that’s not possible. I understand now that I will have to live with this guilt for the rest of my life.”

“I need to stop dwelling on the past and start moving forward. Therefore...”

Yuan turned to look at Azure, who was no longer lying on the ground but standing a few meters away with a calm expression on her face.

“I’m sorry that I couldn’t save you in time, Azure. I’m sorry that I couldn’t defeat the demon fast enough. I broke my last promise to protect you, so let

me make another promise to you. I promise that I will never forget you, regardless of how much pain I feel every time I think of you, and I promise you that I will never let something like this happen again.”

After taking a deep breath, Yuan turned around and began walking away from the Immortal Caves.

“Yuan... Please... Don’t leave me here... Didn’t you promise to protect me?” Azure’s voice resounded from behind him, but Yuan didn’t look back and continued walking away.

“Goodbye, Azure.”

Although he couldn’t see it with his back turned, the scenery behind him was slowly crumbling away into the darkness.

Eventually, Yuan returned to the Stairway to Heaven.

Ding!

[You have passed the fourth trial!]

[Congratulations, you have successfully passed all trials in the Stairway to Heaven!]

[You have gained access to the Second Heaven, Spirit Heaven!]

Tian’er appeared before him a moment later while holding a glowing orb of light with her small hands.

“Congratulations on passing all of the trials, Master. Here is your reward.”

The orb of light flew straight into Yuan’s forehead, and memories immediately began flowing into his head.

Tian’er then pointed at the staircase at the end and said, “Once you climb that staircase with your friends, you will all arrive at Spirit Heaven.”

“But before you go, there is something you must see.”

Tian'er suddenly waved her sleeves, creating a golden door in the middle of the room, which emitted an ancient aura.

“Please.”

Yuan nodded and began walking towards the door.

When he opened the door, Yuan could feel a powerful pressure coming from the other side, but he could not physically see the other side of the door due to the bright light gushing through the door.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan walked through the door and disappeared from the Stairway to Heaven.

Meanwhile, Tian'er teleported those in the spectators' room to her.

“Huh? Where are we?” Chu Liuxiang looked around with a surprised face after the sudden teleportation.

“You're still inside the Stairway to Heaven.” Tian'er said to them.

“Who are you?” Xiao Hua asked her with a slight frown.

“There's no need to be cautious. I am the will of the Stairway to Heaven.”

“Stairway to Heaven's will? I have never heard of such a thing.” Feng Yuxiang said.

“There's a lot that you don't know about the Stairway to Heaven, Vermillion Phoenix.”

“You...” Feng Yuxiang's eyes widened with surprise.

“Where is Brother Yuan?” Xiao Hua then asked.

Tian'er pointed to the golden door behind them, “He's currently in there. He should return shortly.”

“What is behind that door? Can we see?” Chu Liuxiang asked out of curiosity.

Tian’er shook her head and said, “Only he can go inside.”

And sure enough, the door opened a few minutes later with Yuan coming out of the door.

However, there was something strange about him, and he looked a little traumatized.

“Young Master, are you okay?” Feng Yuxiang asked him after seeing his shocked face.

Yuan didn’t respond, almost as though he couldn’t see or hear them.

“What... What was that? Why did you show me such a thing?” Yuan looked at Tian’er and asked after a moment of silence.

“I cannot answer that question. If you want the answers, you must continue climbing,” she calmly responded.

“...”

Yuan closed his eyes and took a moment to calm himself.

When he opened them again, he noticed Xiao Hua and the others.

“Oh? When did you guys appear?” He finally noticed their presence.

“We have been here for a while now... Are you okay, Young Master? What was on the other side of that door?” Feng Yuxiang asked him again.

“I... I really don’t know how to explain it since I also don’t know what I was looking at...” He sighed.

“Anyways, let’s leave this place. I really need some fresh air after what I saw...”

Feng Yuxiang and the others could only nod their heads.

Before they left, Yuan turned to look at Tian'er and asked her, "Will I see you again?"

She nodded, "We will definitely see each other again."

"Then until next time. Goodbye, Tian'er." Yuan smiled at her before walking towards the exit.

"See you later, Master..." Tian'er mumbled in a low voice as she disappeared like a ghost.

As Yuan climbed the final staircase with the others, he wondered out loud, "Once we leave this place, we will leave the Lower Heavens. Where will we appear once we leave this place?"

"There is a designated area for people who successfully climbed the Stairway to Heaven. However, this means that there will be people waiting for us there once we leave this place, and they will be trying to recruit us to their families and sects, so we should prepare ourselves." Feng Yuxiang said.

Chapter 693 - Spirit Heaven

After spending about ten minutes climbing, Yuan and the others finally reached the end of the staircase, where a single door stood.

"I guess we're here." Yuan said as he approached the door and opened it without hesitation.

"Are we ready?" He turned around and asked the ladies following right behind him.

Once they all nodded, Yuan walked through the door, disappearing from the Stairway to Heaven.

Ding!

<You have earned the title 'Carry' from assisting at least one person through the Stairway to Heaven!>

<You have earned the title 'Stairway to Heaven Novice Climber' from successfully climbing the Stairway to Heaven one time!>

Furthermore, an announcement was made for all Players within the Lower Heavens to witness.

<Congratulations! Player Yuan has become the first Player to ascend to 'Spirit Heaven' through the Stairway to Heaven!>

<Because of Player Yuan's efforts, the 'Lower Heavens' has re-established its connection with the 'Spirit Heaven', allowing access for all Players!>

<All Players may now enter the Stairway to Heaven and ascend to Spirit Heaven without any restrictions!>

This announcement shocked all Players currently inside Cultivation Online except for Yuan and his group, as they were no longer in the Lower Heavens, thus unable to see the announcement.

And unbeknownst to Yuan, countless Players began making their way towards the Stairway to Heaven to see for themselves if they could really ascend to the next realm for free.

<You have entered 'Spirit Heaven'>

After entering the door, Yuan found himself in the middle of a spacious square.

He looked around and noticed a few stalls set up not far from him with people idling behind them in a bored manner.

However, when these people noticed Yuan's presence and sudden appearance, their bored faces immediately lit up with excitement, and they all began approaching him like a bunch of hungry pigeons.

However, they stopped moving when they noticed more people appearing out of thin air.

Xiao Hua, Feng Yuxiang, Meixiu, Lan Yingying, Chu Liuxiang, and last but not least, Min Li— six more people appeared after Yuan, which shouldn't be possible.

"E-Excuse me... D-Did you just challenge the Stairway to Heaven?" One of the people there asked Yuan in a trembling voice.

Yuan shifted his head to look at the man before nodding his head, "That's right."

"W-What about the other six behind you...?" The man continued to ask him.

"Yes, they were with me in the Stairway to Heaven." Yuan confirmed.

"I-Impossible!"

"Does this mean he'd helped six other people ascend by carrying them through the Stairway to Heaven? I have never heard of anyone succeeding in such a feat in my life!"

"Heavens! If that's true, then we have an unrivaled genius here!"

Some of these people fell onto their buttocks from shock after hearing Yuan's words.

"Young Master, where should we go now?" Feng Yuxiang ignored the people around them and asked.

"Let's find a place to rest for now," he said.

"Okay."

"P-Please wait a moment, young man! Would you be interested in joining our Silver Blade Academy? We're one of seven Spirit Academies, a top sect in this world. If you join us, we can guarantee you prestige and power!" One of the people there suddenly shouted.

When the others heard this man's recruitment, they also started shouting their own recruitment, as they didn't want to miss this opportunity to recruit a monster like Yuan into their family or sect.

"Join the Wu Family! We're a top ten family within Spirit Heaven! We can promise you unlimited resources as long as we can afford them!"

"Our Chaotic Force Academy is also one of seven Spirit Academies! We can offer you benefits that others cannot!"

The usually calm and quiet area suddenly became chaotic with everyone trying to recruit Yuan.

"Everybody, please listen to me for a moment!" Yuan suddenly shouted, silencing the place.

"I have no interest in joining any family or sect as of this moment, so if you'll excuse me, I have other businesses to attend to!"

And when nobody there moved out of the way so that he could leave, Yuan released his Spirit Lord cultivation base, forcing everyone there to back up.

"He's also a Spirit Lord?! But he's so young!"

However, everybody there was more impressed than scared by Yuan's powerful aura.

Although they were reluctant, the people there made an open path for Yuan to walk.

Once Yuan walked far enough, the people there began following him while contacting their respective families and sects to let them know that an unrivaled genius had arrived in the Spirit Heaven.

As for Yuan and his group, they walked around aimlessly until they found a hotel.

"Min Li, what are you going to do now that we have arrived at Spirit Heaven?" Yuan asked her after they found a room.

"I... I don't really know. I haven't planned this far." She shook her head.

"Take your time. I am going to leave for a few days. You can stay here in the meantime."

"Thank you, Yuan. I will forever be indebted to you."

"Don't even mention it. I helped you because I wanted to, not because I needed something from you. Anyways, I will see you later." Yuan logged off the game shortly after.

Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang also logged off.

After removing the console from his head, Yuan got off the bed and immediately started stretching his body while taking deep breaths.

"It's only been a week, but it feels like I haven't seen this room for much longer." Chu Liuxiang stretched her body on the bed after logging off.

"Huh? You also haven't logged off this entire time?" Yuan was surprised to hear that.

"Nope. I made sure to watch your entire trial from beginning to end, and I must say, it was a fascinating experience. You're almost like a different person in Cultivation Online."

"Really?"

"I think so," she nodded.

"Mostly your demeanor, and I think it makes you cooler."

"Thank you, I guess..."

"Anyways, I am going to take a bath before going to bed since it's night time right now. You can join me if you want.." Chu Liuxiang said to him before entering the bathroom that was in the same room as their bedroom.

Chapter 694 - Opened To All Players

"Darling, you can use the bathroom now." Chu Liuxiang left the bathroom with nothing but her towel that was loosely wrapped around her slim body.

"I also changed the water in the bathtub for you."

"Thank you."

Yuan calmly entered the bathroom shortly after.

Inside the bathroom, Yuan tossed a handful of medicine leaves into the bathtub.

And while he waited for the water to soak the medicine, he went to take a quick shower.

Once the bathtub was ready, Yuan entered it and began absorbing the medicine, tempering his body for the next hour.

By the time he left the bathroom, Chu Liuxiang was already deep asleep while wearing her see-through pajamas.

Yuan focused on her sleeping face for a moment before going to sleep himself.

'I wonder if they managed to trade treasures with the giants safely...' He wondered about the Huang Family as he fell asleep.

Of course, he knew that it was only a trial, but everything felt so real that he couldn't help but think about it.

The following morning, right as the sun peeked over the horizon, Yuan was woken up by the sound of his door being knocked on.

Fortunately for Chu Liuxiang, she was a heavy sleeper, so it didn't wake her up.

"Did something happen, Jinxi?"

Yuan already knew who was knocking on the door before even opening the door because of his Divine Sense.

"Let's spar," she said to him with a calm face.

"You're really eager today..." A bittersweet smile appeared on Yuan's face.

"Sorry, but can you give me a few more days? I don't think I will have the energy to spar with you properly in my current state."

He would normally be willing to train with Li Jinxi and the others, but he was just too exhausted after what he experienced in the Stairway to Heaven.

Although she was reluctant, Li Jinxi nodded her head and said, "Fine, I will give you a few more days. I haven't had a good training session for the past week because you had holed up in your room."

"What about the others?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"They're too weak to satisfy me. Only you can satisfy me, Yuan."

"I see... Anyways, I will spar with you again in a few days after I rest up."

"Okay. See you later." Li Jinxi left without making any commotions shortly after.

Yuan immediately went back to his bed and fell asleep mere seconds later.

A few hours later, Yuan woke up to the smell of Meixiu's cooking even though the kitchen was very far from his room.

He nudged Chu Liuxiang awake and said to her once she was conscious, "Meixiu made breakfast."

"You can go ahead without me. I'm going to skip breakfast to sleep a little longer," she said in a tired voice.

"Okay." Yuan didn't say anything else and went downstairs after washing his face.

"Where's Chu Liuxiang?" Meixiu asked him.

"She's sleeping in."

"Oh! Yuan! You're back! Congratulations on defeating the Stairway to Heaven! It's all over the news and the forums." Wang Ming said as he sat down at the dining table.

The other members showed up around the same time and all sat around the table.

"How difficult were the trials?" Wang Ming asked a moment later.

"They were pretty difficult." Yuan said, and he began recalling his experience in the Stairway to Heaven to the people at the table.

"Wow... I don't think I would be able to do what you did if I were in your shoes. Those are some incredible feats." Shi Lang said.

"Anyways, because you defeated the Stairway to Heaven, we can ascend without needing to wait until we're all Spirit Grandmasters. Thank you for that, Yuan." Wang Ming said afterward.

"Wait... What did you just say?" Yuan raised his eyebrows after hearing Wang Ming's words.

"Hmm? Ever since your ascension, countless players have stormed the Stairway to Heaven so that they can also ascend." Wang Ming said.

"What? Why would they do such a thing? One should be at least a Spirit Grandmaster before they challenge the Stairway to Heaven. These people are only wasting their time." Yuan said, completely unaware of the situation.

"Huh? You didn't see the announcement?" Wang Ming looked at him with a questioning face.

"What announcement?"

"The one after you ascended. There were multiple announcements on that day, and one of them mentioned that the Lower Heavens and Spirit Heavens have established a connection because of your ascension, allowing all Players to ascend without restrictions."

"Wait a second... Without restrictions? Does this mean they can ascend the Stairway to Heaven without needing to do the trials?" Yuan asked with a dumbfounded look on his face.

"That's right. Thousands of Players have already arrived at Spirit Heaven through the Stairway to Heaven, and none of them needed to do any trials. However, the Players can only ascend. They cannot return to the Lower Heavens afterward, which is the only downside."

Yuan was speechless after learning this information.

Why did the Stairway to Heaven suddenly open its doors for everyone and allow all players to ascend for free after he's done all of the hard work? If he waited a little longer to challenge the Stairway to Heaven, would he have also been able to ascend without taking the trials? Could this be Tian'er's doing?

"Unbelievable... I had to endure so much bullshit to ascend, but everyone could suddenly ascend without such hassles immediately afterward? There's no way this could be a coincidence..." Yuan cursed in a low voice.

"Wow, I think this is the first time I've heard you curse, Yuan. Although I understand your feelings, I also believe this to be a good thing, as it allows

the Players more chances to catch up. You're too far ahead, after all."

"Haaaa... Whatever..." Yuan sighed a moment later, "What's done is already done, and it's not like I have any control over it. Anyways, the food is getting cold. Let's continue after breakfast."

Thus, they stopped talking and began eating.

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Chapter 695 - Hypothetically

After breakfast, Wang Ming asked Yuan, "What are you going to do now that you've ascended to the next world?"

"I'm not sure yet. There's so much that I could do that I don't know where to start." Yuan shook his head.

"Do you plan on ascending again?"

"Of course. I want to reach the highest realm there is in Cultivation Online."

"That will probably take a few years."

"Even then, I want to do it— I have to..."

Yuan then asked the others, "What about you guys? Are you still in the Lower Heavens? Do you plan on ascending?"

"I don't know about them, but I also intend on ascending soon." Wang Ming said, and he continued, "However, I need to prepare myself before I ascend. A lot of people ascended without any preparations, and many of these Players have died shortly after arriving because they were not prepared for that place. The monsters there are simply too powerful for them. The worst part is that they're now stuck there without any way of returning to the Lower Heavens."

"That makes sense, since the Spirit Heaven's overall difficulty is higher than the Lower Heavens." Yuan said.

"Despite that fact, there are still a lot of Players ascending." Shi Lang sighed.

"These Players are so greedy for resources that they are blinded by the reality that most of them won't even be able to leave the city without getting killed by monsters that are far above their level."

"Anyways, I will also ascend once I finish preparing myself. Ever since I joined the faction and started living here, I have been spending more time in Cultivation Online."

"I've also started playing more. After morning training and breakfast, I spend the rest of the day in Cultivation Online." Wang Bingbing nodded.

Everyone there shared the same sentiment.

Hearing their words, Yuan then said, "If any of you need cultivation techniques, I can help you out. There's this place called Myriad of Techniques, and because of my connection with them, I can acquire a number of free cultivation techniques every year. Just let me know whenever you arrive in Spirit Heaven. I don't think I will be ascending anytime soon."

"Really? That's great— No, that's amazing! If you can sell some of these techniques, you'll be rich in no time!" Wang Ming exclaimed.

"Sell them?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

He recalled the person working at the Myriad of Techniques telling him that he could sell the techniques if he wishes, and since he's low on money, this could easily become a great money maker.

Furthermore, he managed to rank up his faction recently after slaying the Blood Sect.

"I will give the Myriad of Techniques a visit later." Yuan decided a moment later.

Everyone went back to their own rooms shortly after.

"Meixiu, what are you going to do now?" Yuan asked her as they walked to their rooms, as their rooms are located right next to each other.

"I am very close to reaching the third level of Spirit Warrior, so I am going to try and breakthrough by this week," she said.

"I see... Good luck. If you need anything, let me know." Yuan nodded.

"I will see you later." He said to her once they arrived at their rooms.

"Wait a moment, Yuan." Meixiu suddenly stopped him.

"Umm... It's been a while since I... you know... 'relieved' you... How are you feeling?" She asked him with a slightly bashful face.

"Now that you mention it, we haven't had any chance to be alone since Lulu showed up." Yuan realized this just now.

"Well... She's still asleep, right? We have some time right now if you want to do it..."

After a moment of silence, Meixiu eventually realized how eager she was—even a little desperate to help relieve Yuan, so she took a step back and said, "A-Actually, forget it..."

She quickly opened the door to her room and tried to run away, but Yuan suddenly grabbed her hand and stopped her from escaping.

"Let's do it. I don't have anything else to do now, anyway," he said in a calm voice.

Yuan entered the room with Meixiu a moment later.

After locking the door, Meixiu said, "I will wash your back first."

"Okay." He nodded.

Sometime later, Yuan sat on a small chair in the bathroom while Meixiu rinsed his body with warm water.

Once she began washing his back, Meixiu spoke in a gentle voice, "Yuan, how do you feel about Lulu?"

"What do you mean?"

"She wants to start a family with you, you know?"

"Yes, I know. She seems very eager to do so."

"How do you feel about that? Will you start a family with her?"

Yuan smiled and said, "You know, even back at the orphanage, she loved to play 'pretend family' with me. She would be the mother, and I was the father. We mostly played alone, but there were times when other kids joined, and Lulu would always make them our children, regardless if they were younger or older than us."

"I never really thought about it back then since we were still too young, but I knew that she really wanted her own family in the future."

"Although we haven't seen each other for over a decade, she's still the same Lulu that I knew from the orphanage. If she really wants to start a family with me... I probably wouldn't mind it." Yuan said in a calm voice.

Meixiu subconsciously bit her lips, and she could feel a sharp pain in her heart after hearing his answer.

"I-I see..." She mumbled in a low voice and wouldn't say another word for the next minute.

After a long minute of awkward silence, Meixiu eventually opened her mouth again.

"Yuan... Hypothetically, if I also wanted to start a family with you, what would you do?"

Meixiu could feel her heart trying to burst out of her chest after muttering these words that required all of her courage.

"Eh...?"

Yuan was left speechless by her sudden question, and his mind immediately began scrambling for an answer.

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Chapter 696 - Meixius Commitment

Chapter 696 - Meixiu's Commitment

After a long moment of silence, Yuan sighed with a bittersweet smile on his face, "Asking me to choose between you or Lulu isn't fair, Meixiu. You're both equally important to me, so I don't know what to say."

Yuan chose his words wisely so that he doesn't have to pick one and upset the other.

However, Meixiu wasn't satisfied with such an answer and continued to push him, "That doesn't answer my question. You can either pick one of us... or decide to not pick either of us..."

"..."

Yuan retreated into silence once again.

Seeing this, Meixiu mustered her courage again before speaking, "Yuan... After separating with you because of what was happening at the Jaded Garden, I realized how much I hated it— being separated from you, that is."

"I was also worried that I would lose you to the demon, and the thought of losing you forever nearly drove me crazy..."

She took a deep breath and continued, "I'm not asking you to abandon Lulu and choose only me, but I don't want you to leave me. You know, Lulu told me that she wouldn't mind sharing you with others as long as she could remain by your side."

"I didn't understand her feelings back then, and I even found it quite abnormal. However, I am starting to understand her feelings now. As long as I get to stay by your side, I don't care if you choose to start a family with Lulu or whoever."

"You want me to start a family with you and Lulu? Can I do something like that? How does it even work?" Yuan asked after hearing her words.

"It's definitely uncommon, but it's not impossible. I think the most important thing is that we all come to an agreement. As long as we are all okay with it, it should work out." Meixiu said.

And she continued in a low voice, "Lulu has already given her approval, and I am now giving you my approval, so it's all up to you now, Yuan."

Yuan began pondering Meixiu's words in silence.

Meanwhile, Meixiu started working on the front of his body.

However, since Yuan was busy pondering for an answer, there was no response between his legs.

After a moment of silence, Yuan spoke in a sincere voice, "If I can really start a family with you and Lulu and make the both of you happy at the same time, there's no way that I could refuse."

"Eh...?"

Meixiu stopped washing his body to stare at him with a dazed face.

"D-Does that mean..."

"Yes, I would love to start a family with you and Lulu," he gave her a clear answer with a smile on his face.

Meixiu's body trembled upon hearing his words, and an uncontrollable urge to embrace Yuan rushed into her head.

She then held onto Yuan's face with her soapy hands and gave him a sudden kiss on the lips.

"Meixiu...?" Yuan mumbled her name in a low and surprised tone.

"Yuan... Can you wait for me outside after I rinse your body?" She suddenly said in a bashful voice.

And before Yuan could even respond, she continued, "You don't have to put on your clothes."

Although Yuan was puzzled by her request, he didn't refuse and nodded his head.

Meixiu proceeded to rinse his body with warm water in complete silence before sending him outside.

Yuan began waiting outside with nothing but a towel around his body while Meixiu started washing her body in the bathroom, and she was incredibly thorough when cleaning, making sure that her body was sparkling clean.

'Am I really going to go through with this...?' Meixiu asked herself while she was still inside the bathroom.

'This uncontrollable urge that I am feeling now... Did I get it from my mother?'

'If I do this today, we can never go back...'

'Despite my seemingly rash and bold decision, my mind is clearer than it has ever been at this moment...'

'I... want to be with him. I want to stay by his side... forever.'

After spending a little over five minutes inside the bathroom, Meixiu walked out of the bathroom with nothing but a towel wrapped around her body just like Yuan.

"Sorry for the wait, Yuan," she said after coming out.

"Don't mind it, but what are we doing?"

"..."

After a moment of silence, Meixiu spoke, "I'm going to relieve you now, but it's going to be a little different than usual."

"Different? How?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"You said you'd start a family with me, right?"

"Yes." Yuan confirmed.

"Well... I am going to teach you how to start a family..." Meixiu said with a flushed face.

"Now?" Yuan asked.

"Y-You don't want to? W-We can do this another time if you want..."

Yuan could hear a hint of fear within Meixiu's trembling voice, almost as though she was afraid that he'd refuse.

"No, we can do it now," he suddenly said in a clear voice.

Although he wasn't sure what he was getting himself into, he knew very clearly that Meixiu was anxious about it and that he would hurt her if he refused.

"Are you sure...?"

Yuan nodded with a gentle smile on his face, "If you're sure, then I am also sure."

Thud.

A soft noise suddenly resounded.

Yuan immediately realized what caused that noise just now because he'd heard a similar sound when he was alone with Haung Xiao Li during the second trial.

And sure enough, when he used his divine sense to look at Meixiu, she was completely naked with her towel on the floor.

'Oh...'

It was at this moment Yuan finally realized what they were about to do—that they were going to make love to each other.

Even with his innocent mind, he knew what it meant to make love, especially after regaining some of his past memories.

However, oddly enough, he couldn't feel what he felt with Huang Xiao Li. He didn't reject the idea of making love with Meixiu.

In fact, his body immediately began reacting to the sight of Meixiu's naked body, and a bulge appeared in the middle of his towel.

"Yuan..."

Seeing his body's reaction, Meixiu released a sigh of relief inwardly, and she began approaching him.

She opened her arms and embraced him a moment later, and they both fell onto the bed.

"Yuan... This... This is my commitment to you... My love for you..." Meixiu whispered in a low voice before she kissed him on the bed.

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Chapter 697 - Making Love (18+)

Reader's discretion is advised. Mature content ahead.

Meixiu's locked bedroom was dimly lit with the only light source being the sunlight that peeked through the closed curtains, and currently inside this room, Yuan was lying on the bed with Meixiu lying on his bare chest.

The two of them had been kissing each other for a while now, albeit amateurish, it was more than enough for them to express their feelings for each other.

"What should I do now?" Yuan asked in a low voice after they stopped kissing.

"You don't need to do anything, just lie down and let me do everything. This is also a lesson, after all," she responded in a similarly low voice.

However, Meixiu was no longer feeling nervous and bashful, and it was Yuan who was feeling such emotions, almost as though she'd transferred all of these feelings to Yuan through kissing.

Meixiu suddenly began to kiss his body, slowly moving down with every kiss. And while she was doing that, she was also recalling what her mother taught her.

Even though she had no experience in this sort of thing, Meifeng had made sure to drill enough information into her head through videos and books to make sure that she would satisfy Yuan properly when the time came, and that time is now.

Once Meixiu reached the lower parts of Yuan's body, she used her hand to slow stroke the throbbing rod between Yuan's legs, and it felt hotter than usual, most likely because it has been a while since he was last relieved.

Meanwhile, Yuan watched Meixiu's every movement through his divine sense while being absorbed in this tingling sensation that was making his body filled with excitement, and it was a type of excitement that was different from what he was used to.

And since he was using divine sense, he was able to see every inch of Meixiu's perfect body.

Suddenly, Meixiu changed her movements, and both of Yuan's eyebrows lifted with surprise when Meixiu unexpectedly opened her mouth and placed his rod inside.

This was a revelation for Yuan, who could've never expected that Meixiu would do such a thing.

However, he didn't utter a single word, as the sensation of Meixiu's mouth was heavenly, especially when she started moving her head in a graceful manner, leaving him speechless.

Yuan quickly reached his limit within minutes.

"M-Meixiu... I-I am about to..." He quickly warned her.

She stopped for a moment to speak, "It's okay, you can release it inside my mouth. It's not going to be easy cleaning it if it gets onto the bed sheets."

Yuan wanted to ask her if it was really okay, but he could no longer hold it anymore and climaxed inside her mouth the next moment.

Meixiu could feel a load of hot liquid gush inside her mouth, quickly filling it, but she managed to keep it from overflowing.

Once she was certain that Yuan had emptied himself, she removed her mouth from his rod and swallowed it like a champion.

"Y-You swallowed it?" Yuan asked her in a dazed voice.

Meixiu nodded with a slight blush, and she said, "It's a little sweet..."

Her response left Yuan speechless once again, and he wasn't sure if he really needed to learn such information about himself.

"Looks like you can still continue." Meixiu pointed at his rod that remained standing tall even after his climax.

"Let's move onto the main part of starting a family then, shall we."

Yuan silently nodded his head, and he could only imagine what would happen next.

Seeing his response, Meixiu climbed on Yuan's body and positioned herself directly on top of his rod.

"Are you ready? This is how people make babies and start a family," she said to him.

"Eh? Are we really going to make babies right now?" Yuan asked.

"I-I think it's still too early for us to actually start a family..." She said.

"Then do we really have to do this?"

"People do this not only to make babies, Yuan. There are many reasons why people do this, and making babies is merely one of them. Another reason people do this is to show their love for each other. I love you, Yuan, hence why I want to do this with you..."

"But if you don't want to do this, then—"

"No, let's do it." Yuan quickly responded.

Meixiu didn't say anything else and nodded her head.

She began lowering her body the next moment, slowly inserting Yuan's rod inside her body.

"Y-You're bleeding! Are you okay?!" Yuan exclaimed in a low voice when he noticed blood flowing from where Meixiu was inserting his rod, and she even had a painful expression on her face.

"Y-Yes, I am fine. This will happen when a woman does it for the first time, so this will only happen once in my life..."

Meixiu eventually accepted all of Yuan inside her body. Although it was incredibly painful for her, she couldn't be any happier at this moment, as she'd dreamed of this exact moment for many years.

"I am going to move now."

Once she was comfortable, Meixiu began moving her body slowly.

The moment Meixiu started moving her body, Yuan felt as though someone had dumped a bucket of cold water inside his head, making his mind go blank, and the only thing he could feel was the warmth of Meixiu's body rubbing against him.

Just moments ago, he believed that nothing could beat the sensation of Meixiu's mouth, but she'd proved him wrong.

If Meixiu's mouth felt heavenly, then her body could only be described as otherworldly. It was unlike anything Yuan had experienced before.

Eventually, Yuan could no longer just lie still on the bed, and he also began moving his body.

"That's right... Yuan... T-This is... what it... means to... make love..." Meixiu could barely speak properly, as she was trying her best to not make too much noises, fearing that they could be overheard by someone outside.

Thus, the two of them continued to make love to each other until Yuan had to climax again many minutes later.

"Meixiu, I am going to release it again!" Yuan said to her.

"W-Wait! Don't release it inside—"

However, Yuan had already begun his climax before Meixiu even uttered her first word.

"—me..." Meixiu finished her sentence in a dazed voice as Yuan's hot stuff gushed inside her body.

"Eh? I wasn't supposed to do that?" Yuan asked in an innocent voice after he released everything into her, leaving Meixiu speechless.

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Chapter 698 - Convenience Store

"Yuan... For further references, if you do not plan on impregnating the person you're making love to, you shouldn't release your stuff inside them because that's how you actually make babies... And accidents like that can cause a lot of trouble for you and your partner..." Meixiu didn't know whether to laugh or cry at her predicament.

"D-Does that mean we're going to have a baby soon...? I'm sorry..." Yuan immediately felt bad about his actions, especially since Meixiu had specifically said that she didn't want a baby now.

"Well, it is also my fault for not explaining things to you before we did it. I guess I was also a little impatient..."

"You're not angry?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"No, I'm not." Meixiu shook her head.

And she continued, "Furthermore, it's not like I am guaranteed to have a baby just because you released it inside once. There are also things I can do to prevent it, such as taking birth control pills. They're incredibly effective according to my mother."

"I-If you say so..."

Meixiu looked at Yuan's body a moment later and couldn't help but smile.

"You still have energy to continue? Is it because you're a cultivator, or is it just your body that's vigorous?" She wondered out loud.

"I don't know..." Yuan responded honestly.

"Do you want to continue?" Meixiu suddenly asked.

"I-I do!" He eagerly nodded.

And the two of them continued making love to each other for 3 more hours.

Once they were fully satisfied, Meixiu took Yuan into the bathroom to wash his body again.

"Yuan... Please keep what happened today a secret from the others, especially Yu Rou... Who knows how she'll react if she finds out what we did..." Meixiu said to him as she washed his body.

"Don't worry, my lips are sealed." Yuan said with a smile.

In fact, he's had a smile on his face for the past three hours.

"Okay, you're clean. You can leave after putting your clothes on. I will clean everything up." Meixiu said after rinsing his body.

Yuan nodded, and as he dried his body with a towel, he asked her, "Meixiu... Do you think we can do this again in the future?"

Meixiu was left speechless for a good moment by his question.

"I-If we get the chance..." She nodded in a bashful manner.

Now that she's released all of her passion in bed and is no longer hot-headed, Meixiu remembered what embarrassment is and returns to her quiet nature.

Yuan left Meixiu's room after putting his clothes back on and returned to his own room shortly after.

"She's still asleep? It is almost noon..." Yuan was amazed by Chu Liuxiang's ability to sleep for so long.

He didn't want to disturb Chu Liuxiang, so he went to the balcony to cultivate.

And to his absolute surprise, it suddenly became much easier to cultivate for some reason. He was absorbing an abundant amount of spiritual energy with barely any effort, and the spiritual energy flowing through his spiritual veins was traveling at a much quicker speed.

It was almost as though he'd consumed a priceless treasure, but he doesn't recall using any recently.

Yuan didn't know this at the time, but his talents had actually increased after making love with Meixiu, who had a divine body and was also a maiden.

Meanwhile, Meixiu also left her room after cleaning her body.

In fact, she left the house altogether, and in her hand was a piece of paper that had a map of the Dragon Spiral Mountain.

After looking at the map for a bit, she found the convenience store which was only a few minutes away from their residence.

In order to make things convenient for its residents, the Dragon Spiral Mountain has multiple convenience stores around the mountain so the residents could purchase fresh groceries without needing to leave the mountain and travel to a city.

Meixiu expected the convenience store to be a small building, but to her surprise, it was actually the size of a small mall that had multiple floors and stores inside.

The only difference between this mall and the malls in the cities is that this mall was completely empty, and Meixiu felt like she was alone in her own world.

After looking around on the first floor, Meixiu found the store she was looking for and went inside.

"Welcome—! Oh? I haven't seen you before. Are you new here?"

There was a beautiful woman at the register that greeted Meixiu the moment she walked inside.

"Yes." Meixiu nodded.

"How long have you been living here?"

"About a week."

"I see, I see. And what are you looking for today?"

Meixiu looked around to make sure nobody else was there.

"It's okay, we are alone here." The woman smiled at her actions, finding it cute.

"T-Then can I get some birth control pills?" Meixiu said in a low voice.

The woman's eyes widened with surprise after hearing Meixiu's needs. It was truly way out of her expectations.

She suddenly chuckled and said, "Your boyfriend is a very lucky man to have a beautiful young lady like you. How many pills do you want? A single box can last you a month."

"Just a box is fine," Meixiu quickly replied.

"I understand. What about some rubber? You want those for your boyfriend as well?"

"Rubber?" Meixiu raised her eyebrows.

"Condoms. This way, you won't need to continuously take pills. However, your boyfriend might not like using them, and it won't feel as good when you do it." The woman gave her a detailed explanation.

"Oh..." Meixiu went silent for a moment before speaking, "It's okay... I will just take the pills."

"You got it! Don't worry, I also prefer it without the rubber." The woman chuckled again.

She reached under her counter and retrieved a box.

"Take one pill a day for the next four weeks until you run out, and make sure you don't miss any days, or the pills won't be as effective. Trust me, you don't want that. Once you only have a week of supplies left, you should come back for more just in case you cannot buy more for whatever reason."

"Okay. How much for it?"

"Hmm? It's free. In fact, everything in this mall is free. You didn't know that?" The woman said.

Meixiu shook her head and she asked, "Then why are you working here?"

"I'm just here for customer service."

"I see..."

"Here, let me bag it up for you."

The woman then wrapped the birth control pills with black wrappings so that nobody can tell what is inside without opening it.

"Thank you."

"See you next month!" The woman waved goodbye at Meixiu with a bright smile on her face.

After leaving the store, Meixiu decided to stock up on groceries since she was already there.

Once Meixiu returned to her own room, she took her first birth control pill before hiding the rest under her mattress on the bed.

"I can't believe I am actually taking birth control pills..." Meixiu mumbled to herself.

She laid on her bed that still lingered with Yuan's fragrance a moment later, making it feel like he was still in the room.

"Yuan..." Meixiu closed her eyes and spent the rest of the day recalling their intimate experience.

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Chapter 699 - Until The End Of The Month

"Mmm..." Chu Liuxiang woke up from her long slumber when it was almost evening.

After stretching her body on the bed, she sat up and looked around the dark room with a dazed face.

She quickly noticed Yuan, who was still cultivating in the balcony.

After staring at Yuan's figure for a couple of moments, she got off the bed and went inside the bathroom to wash her face.

As she walked out of the bathroom, she noticed her cell phone ringing.

"Father? I wonder what he wants..."

Chu Liuxiang answered the call after realizing who the caller was.

"Hello? Father? Did something happen?"

"My dear daughter... When do you plan on letting us know that you have returned to the mountain?" Chu Shijian's sighing voice resounded through the phone.

"Oh, I completely forgot. Sorry, father. I planned on calling you once I settled in this place, but I had spent the past week inside Cultivation Online." Chu Liuxiang said.

"Cultivation Online? You never showed interest in that game before. In fact, you even refused to play it after trying it out for a few days." Her father said

in a surprised voice.

"Well, I didn't have Yuan by my side before, and I had no reason to play. Things are different now that we're playing together. The game seems so much more intriguing when I follow him compared to playing with the family."

"Yuan... I heard about his most recent achievement. He'd opened a floodgate to the next realm for all players."

"And I was there to witness everything from the beginning to end! If you were there to witness his trials and what he had to endure, you would admire him even more!" Chu Liuxiang said in a somewhat proud voice.

"..."

After a moment of silence, Chu Shijian asked her, "When do you plan on coming back to the family? You're already back in the Dragon Spiral Mountain, so you might as well come back to us now."

Chu Liuxiang quickly responded, "On the contrary, father, now that I have returned to the mountain, I can stay with Yuan as long as I want since I am, technically, already home."

"You... Aiya... Forget it. I will give you until the end of the month with him."

"W-Wait—!"

However, Chu Shijian hung up the phone before she could even respond.

Chu Liuxiang stared at her phone in a dazed manner.

"Until the end of the month..." she mumbled to herself.

She looked at the calendar a moment later only to realize that she has less than three weeks left before the Chu Family starts making things difficult for her and Yuan if she doesn't return.

"Were you talking to someone just now?" Yuan's voice suddenly resounded as he returned to the room after he ended his cultivation.

"I was just speaking to my father on the phone..." She sighed.

"I see... Did something happen to your father? You seem down..."

"That's because he wants me to return to the family, and he has given me until the end of the month to return..." She said with a bittersweet smile.

"Oh... But your family also lives on the mountain, right? I don't think it's going to be that bad, since we're basically neighbors."

Chu Liuxiang shook her head, "It's not that simple. Once I return to the family, they will most likely start arranging my future and forbid me from leaving the house. By the time I am allowed to leave, I would already be married to someone chosen by my family, and I would most likely have to leave this place."

Yuan frowned when he heard this even though he's already heard similar words from Sebastian back at the Jaded Garden.

"Are you okay with that?" Yuan asked her after a moment of silence.

"Of course not! My desire is to start a family with you! You should already know that!" She quickly refuted.

"But does your family know that?"

"..."

Chu Liuxiang didn't immediately respond this time because she has never mentioned it to her family.

"No..." She eventually muttered in a low voice.

"Then you should let them know your feelings."

"That won't do anything. They will simply refuse and do as they please, anyway. That's just how the Chu Family operates."

"You won't know for certain until you do it. Don't worry, even if they refuse, they can't force you to do something that you don't want, because I will be there for you." Yuan smiled.

"Really?"

He nodded and said, "One thing that I cannot stand is when a family forces their own children, adopted or not, to do things against their will, as I have experienced first-hand how horrible that feels."

"If the Chu Family still refuses to listen, then I will forcefully take you away from them just like how I took Min Li from her family."

"You promise?"

"Yes, I promise."

Sometime later, Yuan and Chu Liuxiang went downstairs for dinner, but to their surprise, dinner wasn't prepared, and Meixiu was nowhere to be seen.

"Did Meixiu forget to cook dinner? How rare..." Wang Ming said when he arrived at the dining room and saw the empty table.

"It's only been a week since we've started living together and it already feels off when she misses a single meal. I think we're relying on her too much." Wang Bingbing said.

"I will go check up on her just in case." Yuan said to them.

He arrived at her room a few minutes later and knocked on her door.

"Meixiu, are you in there?"

The door opened a moment later and Meixiu came outside while wearing her pajamas.

"Did something happen?" she asked him.

"I was about to ask you the same... Everyone is wondering about dinner."

It was at this moment that Meixiu realized she'd forgotten about dinner.

"I forgot about dinner... Sorry."

"It's okay, you don't need to apologize. But what should we do about dinner now?"

Meixiu pondered for a moment before speaking, "Well, there's this convenience store a few minutes away, and they have a couple of restaurants there. Maybe we can eat out today."

"That sounds great. I will tell the others, you can take your time.." Yuan said before returning to the dining room to let the others know of the situation.

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Chapter 700 - Plans For Tomorrow

After she fixed her appearance and dressed appropriately, Meixiu went outside to find Yuan and the others.

"Sorry for this... I lost track of time and forgot about dinner." Meixiu apologized to the others.

"Don't worry about it. It's not even your obligation to cook for us, so we cannot complain even if you decide to stop cooking for us." Wang Bingbing said to her.

"My sister's right. If you need a break, just let us know. We can take care of our own dinner," said Wang Ming.

"By the way, who knew there were restaurants on this mountain? I wasn't aware of their existence until Meixiu mentioned it and I looked it up." Shi Lang said.

"I was also surprised by this information." Xi Murong agreed.

"I saw a tall building on our way to the mansion. Perhaps that's where they are located," Wu Zao recalled seeing a mall.

"Yes, that's the place." Meixiu confirmed.

"There are other stores besides restaurants there, such as a convenience store, and even clothing stores, just like a real mall."

"I was also told by a worker there that everything inside the mall is free."

"What? Really? That sounds too good to be true." Wang Ming said.

"Does it? If you think about it, we paid four billion dollars for a house here. That's more than enough to buy multiple malls, not to mention our ridiculous property tax." Wang Bingbing said.

"That doesn't sound like a good idea, though. What if someone decides to take everything in the store? They can make decent money from doing that if they wished." Hong Xiuquan asked.

"That won't happen." Chu Liuxiang said.

"I have lived here for over a decade, and there has been no such case. First of all, everybody living in this place is so rich that they don't really need any more money, so they wouldn't go through the hassle of selling things from the mall. Secondly, it would ruin their dignity and face if word gets out, and nothing is more important than face in a society like this."

"Lastly, if you abuse the mountain's generosity, they can easily take it away from you. Nobody dares to offend the Lord of this mountain, who can evict anybody living in this mountain even if they're permanent residents."

"I have heard of this Lord a couple of times now, but I couldn't find any information about him. Have you seen the lord before, Miss Chu?" Wang Ming asked her.

She shook her head, "No, I have not. In fact, I don't think my parents have seen him before either. He's just that mysterious and seclusive."

"Rumor is that he's a powerful cultivator who has surpassed the limits of what a human can achieve, but we probably won't ever learn the legitimacy of such rumors," Chu Liuxiang shrugged.

"Surpassed human limits..." Yuan mumbled to himself, and his interest—curiosity for this Lord reached a new level.

After arriving at the mall, they all agreed on a restaurant and went inside for dinner.

Sometime later, Yuan and the others left the restaurant after dinner, but they didn't immediately go back home.

Instead, they hung around the mall for another hour like a group of friends after a long day at school.

"Wow, these clothes are all brand names. The Lord of the mountain is truly a generous fellow to be giving out these expensive clothes for free!" Wang Bingbing was surprised by what she saw in the mall.

Most of the clothes found inside the mall were designer clothes that can cost thousands of dollars each.

Purses, shoes, perfumes, sport equipment, fishing gear, weapons, armor—they could find almost anything inside this mall with most of the items being luxury goods.

After their tour around the mall ended, Yuan and the others returned home.

"I am definitely going to return to that mall tomorrow, and I am going to take my time." Wang Bingbing declared as they approached the entrance to their home.

"I'm also going to go back later. I saw a few things that attracted my interest, and I want to take a closer look at them." Wang Ming agreed.

"They had a pretty nice collection of fans in one of the stores there." Wu Zao said.

Almost everyone there wanted to return to the mall after seeing what it had to offer.

"Goodnight, everyone."

"Goodnight."

They returned to their own rooms shortly after.

"You look like you had fun tonight." Chu Liuxiang said to Yuan as they walked back to their room.

"Of course. I did not have any friends back then—not that I would have the time or opportunity to hang out like we did today even if I had friends."

"I can relate to that." Chu Liuxiang said.

And she continued, "We should go back as well— just the two of us. It'll be like a date!"

Yuan nodded.

"Goodnight, Meixiu." Yuan said to her, who was following behind them because her room was in the same direction.

"Goodnight." Meixiu nodded before going inside her room.

"What are you going to do tomorrow?" Chu Liuxiang asked him in bed as they prepared to sleep.

"A few things, actually. After morning training with Li Jinxi and the others, I am going to enter Cultivation Online and visit the Myriad of Techniques to see if my new faction rank changed anything. Then I am going to look for an auction house to sell all of the treasures I picked up from the Blood Sect and the Gu Family... Oh, right, I have to find an Array Master to remove the seals of their previous owners before I can take out the treasures to sell."

"I see... Well, wake me up when you do so I don't sleep through it! I also want to be there with you tomorrow!"

"You can still sleep that much after sleeping for the entire day?" Yuan was baffled by her ability to sleep.

If Yuan's talent is to eat a lot of food, Chu Liuxiang's talent is to sleep a lot. Fortunately for them, their talents are separated in two different bodies, or it would be quite disastrous for their health and future if all they do is eat and sleep all day.

"Goodnight, darling." Chu Liuxiang gave him a quick kiss on the cheeks before submerging herself under the blankets.

"Goodnight, Lulu..."

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Chapter 701 - Spirit Heavens

Sudden Increase In Population

Chapter 701 - Spirit Heaven's Sudden Increase In Population

The following morning, Yuan woke up earlier than anticipated and decided to let Chu Liuxiang sleep a little longer while he went to train with the others.

"I thought you needed a few days to rest." Li Jinxi said to him when he arrived.

"I guess I didn't need that much time to rest, after all."

Li Jinxi had no complaints, and the two of them began sparring with each other until it was time for breakfast.

Yuan returned to his room to wake Chu Liuxiang up before entering the bathroom for a quick shower.

Once they were prepared, they went downstairs and into the dining room together.

Of course, breakfast was already prepared by Meixiu by the time they arrived.

"Meixiu, we can hire someone to cook for us instead if you want. I feel bad for letting you spoil us." Wang Bingbing said to her.

"I don't mind it, really. I consider cooking as a hobby, and I really do enjoy cooking for everyone," she said.

Wang Bingbing smiled and said, "You're not only pretty but also hard working and great with housework. You'll be a great wife in the future, and your future husband is definitely one lucky man."

"Thank you..." Meixiu responded with a slight blush on her face.

When Wang Bingbing mentioned her future husband, all of the men in the room glanced at Yuan, who already had his mouth full of food.

If it wasn't so painfully obvious that Meixiu and Yuan shared a special connection, they would have definitely tried to approach her as a potential partner.

After all, Meixiu is an incredibly charming young lady. It would only be natural for the others to be attracted to her.

The same could be said for Chu Liuxiang, but it was clear to the others that she only has Yuan in her eyes.

Thus, these young men could only try their luck elsewhere.

After breakfast, everyone returned to their room.

"We're going to visit the Myriad of Techniques today. Do you want to come with us?" Yuan asked Meixiu as they walked to their rooms.

"I couldn't cultivate yesterday, so I plan on doing that today," she shook her head.

"Okay."

"Good luck."

"You too."

Once Yuan entered his room, he and Chu Liuxiang logged into Cultivation Online.

"Good morning, Brother Yuan." Xiao Hua and the others greeted them.

"Morning."

"Have you figured out what you want to do now, Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang asked him.

"Yes, I am going to give the Myriad of Techniques a visit today."

He then turned to look at Min Li and asked her, "What about you? Have you figured out your plans yet?"

She shook her head and sighed, "I'm actually still trying to accept the reality that I am really in Spirit Heaven. However, I am probably going to join a sect and start from there."

"Speaking of sect... Did you tell the Dragon Essence Temple that you were leaving?" Yuan suddenly asked.

"Uhh..." Min Li stared at him with a dumbfounded face.

Clearly, she didn't tell the sect.

"Actually, I am still a disciple at the Dragon Essence Temple since I didn't expect to ascend when I was called back home, but there's nothing I can do now that I am here. They will most likely visit the Min Family when I don't return to the sect after some time and learn the truth... hopefully."

"Until I am ready to move on, I hope you don't mind if I continue following you, Yuan."

He nodded, "I understand. You can follow me for as long as you need."

"Thank you."

Yuan and the others left the hotel shortly after to look for the Myriad of Techniques.

"Wow, there's a lot of people in the city today." Feng Yuxiang immediately noticed the sudden increase in population within the city.

"They must be the Players that rushed to the Stairway to Heaven..." Chu Liuxiang said to Yuan.

"Most likely." He agreed with her.

A lot of the Players there stuck out like a sore thumb because of their unnatural demeanor and otherworldly aura that was a stark contrast to the natives in the cultivation world.

However, as Players slowly get used to the cultivation world and its nature in the future, they will definitely become harder to identify.

As for Yuan, he has completely adapted to the cultivation world. From his appearance to his aura— it was almost as though he has belonged in this world since the beginning.

"Hey, Yuan. I wonder if this world is in shock right now because of the rush. If you think about it, there's nothing natural about thousands of Players suddenly ascending from the Lower Heavens." Chu Liuxiang suddenly said.

Yuan immediately began pondering, "Now that you mention it... I wonder how this world is reacting and dealing with the current situation."

Of course, the Spirit Heaven is in complete chaos at this moment.

The people that were there when Yuan ascended to this world believed that he was a peerless genius when he showed up with Chu Liuxiang and the others, but when more Players suddenly started showing up in groups, they began to doubt their own judgement.

When news spread that thousands of people had ascended on the same day, the people of this world wondered if something had happened to the Stairway to Heaven.

After all, most of these people that came out of the Stairway to Heaven and entered their world from the Lower Heavens were only Spirit Apprentices, and nobody believed for a second that a Spirit Apprentice could possibly climb the Stairway to Heaven, much less thousands of them at once.

Therefore, they could only come to the conclusion that the Stairway to Heaven is broken, hence their current situation.

However, there was nothing the natives of this world could do but let the Players swarm their world.. At the end of the day, the Players have already ascended, and it was not as though they could force the Players to go back to the Lower Heavens.

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Chapter 702 - Free Divine-Rank Technique

After leaving the hotel, Yuan and the others wandered around the city asking the pedestrians if there was a Myriad of Techniques in the city while trying their best to avoid the Players.

After half an hour of speaking to random people, they eventually found the right person to speak with.

"Yes, the Myriad of Techniques should be five blocks down that direction."

"Thank you!"

Once Yuan had the directions, they immediately made their way to the store.

"Welcome to the Myriad of Techniques. If this is your first time at our store, please put your hand on this crystal ball." A woman that Yuan didn't recognize greeted them at the entrance.

'It's a different person again... How often do they change out the workers here?' Yuan wondered to himself.

Chu Liuxiang placed her hands on the crystal ball since this is her first time at the store.

And sure enough, just like everyone that follows Yuan, she had a heavenly destiny.

"A heavenly destiny!" The woman was surprised to see the results.

"Congratulations! You can access the first and second floor of the store!"

Min Li touched the crystal ball next.

"You have a minor destiny. You may access the first floor." The woman said after looking at her results.

'A minor destiny?' Yuan raised his eyebrows, as he'd expected Min Li to have a heavenly destiny just like everyone else.

However, unbeknownst to Yuan, Min Li was born without even a minor destiny. It was only after she met him that her destiny had changed from having no destiny to a minor destiny, which is an extremely rare occurrence.

After they entered the store, Yuan said to the others, "I am going to speak with the person working at the front desk. If you guys want to look at techniques while I am away, go ahead."

"I don't really care about the techniques, so I am going to continue follow you." Chu Liuxiang said.

"I will do the same as well." Min Li said.

Yuan already knew Feng Yuxiang and the others' response, so he didn't ask them.

Sometime later, he arrived at the front desk, where a familiar face was working.

"You're still working here?" Yuan was surprised to see the same young man from all of his previous visits.

"Hmm? Oh! Esteemed guest! It's good to see you again!" The young man also recognized Yuan.

"Why are you surprised that I am still working here? Would you rather that I get fired?" He continued with a bittersweet smile on his face.

"No, that's not why I asked. The lady working at the front door changed again since my last visit, so I was wondering if everyone here can only work in this place for a certain amount of time." Yuan said.

"Ah, I see. Only the those working at the front door and the guards here get changed every few weeks. I am a permanent worker in this place, so unless I am fired, I won't go anywhere anytime soon."

"I see..."

"Anyways, why have you returned this time? Are you looking for more techniques?" The young man then asked.

"Not exactly. My faction rank increased to Warrior not long ago, and I was wondering if there are any changes to my benefits."

"What? Your rank increased? But it hasn't even been a full year since you joined the faction! I have never seen anyone progress so quickly before! How did you do it?" The young man was surprised to hear that Yuan had become a Warrior within the faction already.

"I kind of destroyed an entire evil sect..." Yuan said with a slight smile.

"Amazing! No wonder your rank rose so quickly! One already gets a lot of points by killing an evil cultivator, and you destroyed an entire evil sect!" The young man's admiration for Yuan was as clear as day.

And he continued, "As for your benefits, indeed you get to receive more benefits now that your rank has improved."

"Instead of 10 free techniques a year, you now get to choose 20 free techniques every year. However, that's not all. Although it's only a one-time thing, you also get to receive a Divine-rank technique for free that doesn't count towards the 20 techniques."

"20 free techniques and a free Divine-rank technique?" Yuan's jaw dropped upon hearing his upgraded benefits.

Chu Liuxiang and Min Li were also dumbfounded after learning about his benefits for the first time, and they wondered how he got these benefits in the first place.

"Since you still have 4 free techniques from before, you now have 14 free techniques for this year." The young man said, and he continued, "If you wish to pick your Divine-rank technique, you'll need to head to the fourth floor, which you should have access to if you came here from the Spirit Heaven."

"Fourth floor? But my friends can only access up to the second floor. Is there any way for them to come with me?" Yuan asked.

"Normally, they would need permission from someone with authority, but since you're part of the Celestial Overlords, and a Warrior-rank at that, you can bring them with you, but they cannot wander."

"I understand. That's good enough."

"If you need anything else, you know where to find me."

Yuan and the others began making their way to the 4th floor, where all of the Heaven-rank and Divine-rank cultivation techniques could be found.

"Is it just me or are there too few people in this place?" Yuan noticed this as they walked through each floor. "The Myriad of Techniques is connected to every store in the Nine Heavens, right? This place should be crowded if that was the case."

"Who knows. The Myriad of Techniques is more mysterious and profound than we can fathom. Perhaps you can ask one of the workers here if you're really curious." Feng Yuxiang said.

He nodded, "I will do just that after we're done looking at the techniques."

Sometime later, they arrived on the fourth floor, and to their surprise, it was multiple times larger than the previous three floors combined.

Chapter 703 - The Real Myriad Of Techniques

"Wow... Just how massive is this place? I cannot even see the end of the room from here!" Yuan mumbled in a dazed voice.

"Can you even call this a 'room'? There's a clear sky as the ceiling!" Chu Liuxiang said as she stared at the sky above them.

"That's not a real sky. It's only an illusion created by the formation." Feng Yuxiang said.

"What's the point of that?"

"For the atmosphere, I guess."

"There's also a lot more people on this floor." Yuan said.

"How does one find the cultivation techniques they are looking for in this vast place? It would take days if not longer to check every shelf in here."

Just as Yuan asked that question, he noticed that not far away from them, there was a stall with the sign 'Customer Support' written on it.

"Nevermind. Let's go over there."

"Hello, how may I help you?" The woman working the desk greeted them when they got close.

"Hello, I am wondering if there's a map or something that could help us navigate this place." Yuan asked her.

"This must be your first time here. Give me a second."

The woman reached under her desk and retrieved a jade slip before handing it to him.

"You will have all the information you need inside. If you're looking for a certain cultivation technique or a certain category, it's all there."

"Thank you." Yuan accepted the jade slip.

"There's something else you should know about this place." The woman continued.

"Looking at the place now, you might be thinking that this place is massive, but that's not entirely correct."

"What do you mean?"

"The Myriad of Techniques itself is actually a formation, so what you're seeing isn't always the truth. Look in that direction." The woman pointed north.

"Do you see that stall all the way in the distance?"

"Yes, I see it."

"Well, all the cultivation techniques from here to there are unique, but once you reach that stall, the cultivation techniques will be the same."

"Huh?" Yuan raised his eyebrows in a puzzled manner.

"Although you cannot see it, there's actually a wall that separates us. We're essentially inside a giant invisible box, and this invisible box is separated by hundreds of smaller invisible boxes, and inside each box is technically a store of its own, but it contains the same cultivation techniques as every other box."

"That's..." Yuan was speechless by this complex information.

"I know it's a lot to take in and understand. In simpler terms, we're currently inside a massive store that has many smaller stores in it, and each of these stores contain the same content. It's so the store doesn't become too crowded."

"Wow, that sounds like how parallel universes would work. We're currently in one store, but there are many other stores exactly like this one, and it's all in the same place. Can we go to the other stores from here?" Chu Liuxiang suddenly asked.

"Yes, but there's really no point, since you won't find anything new there." The woman nodded.

"How do you decide which room the customer goes to? Is it random?" Yuan then asked.

"Not exactly. It will depend on your destiny and where you entered the store from," she said.

"Is this how the previous three floors function?"

"Yes."

"No wonder why there were barely any people on those floors... Turns out there were other stores and we just couldn't see them." Yuan mumbled in a dazed voice.

"I cannot imagine how many stores there are in this place..." Chu Liuxiang shook her head.

"It's actually not as bad as you expect. Not everyone in the Nine Heavens is allowed to use the Myriad of Techniques, after all. In fact, out of a hundred thousand people, perhaps around ten of them would be allowed to enter this place."

"There are 2,000 stores on this floor, and we're currently at floor number 9."

"Eh? Really? I didn't know that, since everyone I know was allowed entrance." Yuan said.

"It's either a coincidence or they know someone who has a strong enough destiny to alter their fate, allowing them to enter." The woman smiled.

And she continued, "There are some really powerful people out there who can alter others' destiny just by being with them."

"I see..."

"Anyways, if you need help with anything else, you know where to find me."

"Thank you for all the information." Yuan said to the woman before leaving her alone.

He looked into the jade slip a moment later, and sure enough, information about the fourth floor began flooding into his head.

"Do you guys want any techniques? If you have something in mind, just let me know and I will see if it's available." Yuan said to the others afterward.

Feng Yuxiang and Xiao Hua shook their heads.

Lan Yingying said, "I am still trying to fully master the one from last time."

"Thank you for the offer, but I have already received more than enough from you. I cannot rely on you for everything." Min Li said.

"Since nobody else wants one, I will take one! I don't have any cultivation techniques, anyway." Chu Liuxiang said.

Yuan nodded and asked her, "What kind of techniques are you looking for?"

"I'm not sure."

Yuan began pondering.

"What style do you prefer? For example, I use the sword and dagger, so I would prefer using sword and dagger techniques."

"I don't really specialize in any weapons," she said.

Yuan then looked at the experts for help.

"Are there any suitable techniques for cultivators that don't use weapons?"

Feng Yuxiang nodded, "Yes, there's a lot. Most cultivators who don't use weapons can only rely on their internal energy to fight, and most cultivation techniques out there use internal energy."

"What's the difference between internal energy and spiritual energy?" Yuan asked.

"Well, spiritual energy is what we absorb, and internal energy is what spiritual energy becomes after being absorbed and refined. In essence, it's our cultivation." Feng Yuxiang explained.

"But to be honest, they're pretty much the same thing. Some people prefer calling it spiritual energy while others call it internal energy.. In the end, it's all about preferences."

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Chapter 704 - Spiritual Veins

"If most techniques are for people who use internal energy, how does that help me find one that's suitable?" Chu Liuxiang asked.

"If you're looking for a suitable technique, then you should pick a technique that compliments the attribute of your Spiritual Veins." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Spiritual Veins? What is that, and how do I find my attribute?"

"Spiritual Veins are organs that cultivators produce alongside their Dantian when they first become cultivators, and they are actually what absorbs the spiritual energy in the air. The higher the quality of one's Spiritual Veins, the easier and faster their cultivation will be." Feng Yuxiang explained.

And she continued, "For example, if two cultivators start cultivating from the same starting point, the one with ordinary Spiritual Veins might reach Spirit Warrior in four years, but the one with better quality Spiritual Veins will be able to reach that same level within half the time."

"Spiritual Veins can also possess certain attributes, making the cultivation of certain techniques easier and faster. If someone has fire attribute Spiritual Veins, they would be able to learn fire techniques twice as fast if not even faster than someone that does not have fire attribute Spiritual Veins. Of course, not all Spiritual Veins possess an attribute."

"As for how one can tell if their Spiritual Veins possess an attribute, there are treasures out there that do the job. Do you want to see if your Spiritual Veins possess an element?" Feng Yuxiang asked Chu Liuxiang afterward.

"Yes, I would like to know my element— if I have one." Chu Liuxiang nodded.

"Okay, but since I don't have such treasures right now, we will have to do this another way. I will require a drop of your blood." Feng Yuxiang said.

"My blood?"

"Yes, I can identify if your Spiritual Veins possess an element through your blood by tasting it."

"You're going to drink my blood...?" Chu Liuxiang raised her eyebrows, feeling a little uneasy about letting someone drink her blood.

Feng Yuxiang smiled and said, "In case you forgot, I am not human. I am a Divine Beast."

"You're a what?!" Min Li exclaimed in a shocked voice after hearing Feng Yuxiang's words, as she wasn't aware of such facts until now.

"Indeed, I am not human. I am actually a Vermillion Phoenix," she confirmed.

"A real phoenix...?" Min Li felt her strength being sucked out of her body after learning that she had been traveling with a Divine Beast this entire time— a Phoenix, at that.

"If you don't want to do it now, we can do it later when we have the treasure." Feng Yuxiang said a moment later.

"It's fine, we can do it now. It's just a drop of blood, right?" Chu Liuxiang said.

"Yes."

Chu Liuxiang poked a small hole on her finger before letting Feng Yuxiang lick the blood being squeezed out.

"Hmm..." Feng Yuxiang closed her eyes and focused on appraising her element.

"Congratulations, you possess a rare attribute for your Spiritual Veins, and that element is ice."

"Is that any good? I can't tell." Chu Liuxiang asked.

"Of course. Any rare attribute is good. Your ice element is basically a superior version of the water element. They say only one in one million cultivators have a rare attribute."

"That's great to hear. Congratulations, Lulu." Yuan said to her.

And he continued, "Feng Feng, can you also see if my Spiritual Veins possess any element?"

Feng Yuxiang smiled and said, "Young Master, I have already tried looking at your Spiritual Veins many times, but I couldn't taste anything."

"Eh? Does that mean I don't possess elemental Spiritual Veins?" Yuan felt a little disappointed by the results.

However, Feng Yuxiang quickly said, "That's not entirely correct, Young Master. I should've worded it better. It's more like I couldn't tell. In other words, I don't know if you have an attribute or not."

"How is that any better?" Yuan asked.

"Because that means you might possess elemental Spiritual Veins, but they are too high quality for me to tell."

"If you really want to learn about your attribute, we will need the proper treasure."

"I understand..." Yuan nodded.

"Then we'll start looking for techniques with Water and Ice elements."

After looking through the jade slip for a few moments, Yuan began walking around the fourth floor, picking out all of the techniques that complimented Chu Liuxiang's Spiritual Veins.

"That's a lot of techniques..." Chu Liuxiang mumbled in a dazed voice before the mountain of scrolls before her.

"There's around 60 techniques for you to choose from." Yuan said with a smile.

"This is going to take a while..."

"Take your time. I'm also going to look around."

After helping Chu Liuxiang carry the techniques to a nearby table, Yuan left to look for his own technique.

Feng Yuxiang and Min Li stayed with Chu Liuxiang to make sure she wasn't bothered and to give advice if needed.

Meanwhile, Yuan pondered about what kind of technique he wanted.

'I already have plenty of sword techniques but only one dagger technique. I should look for a new dagger technique.'

With that in mind, Yuan began searching for dagger techniques in the jade slip.

Once he found where the techniques' were located in the store, he went to look at them on the shelves.

'Phantom Blade Dance... Earth-rank... '

'Poison Blade Barrage... Heaven-rank...'

'Blade of a Thousand Cuts... Heaven-rank'

"Oh? This Ten Thousand Ghost Blades technique seems very powerful..." Yuan immediately took a liking to the technique after looking at its description.

<Ten Thousand Ghost Blades>

<Rank: Divine>

<Description: Creates up to 10,000 ghost weapons of the user's weapon and control each of them as though they are a separate weapon. Must wield a dagger to activate. Requires 10,000 Qi per second for each ghost weapon created.>

'Does this mean I can basically have up to 10,000 Starry Abyss fighting for me at once? Will I even be able to control that many at once?' Yuan closed his eyes and imagined ten thousand flying daggers surrounding him.

'The only downside is its enormous Qi requirements... If I activate 10,000 ghost weapons at once, that means it will consume 100 million Qi every second. How much Qi do I even have at the moment? I can't tell because of the bugged system...'

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Chapter 705 - South Wing City

'Even though it will cost a lot of Qi to use this technique to its full potential, I don't think I will really need all 10,000 ghost weapons. 100 is already more than enough, much less 10,000.' After pondering for some time, Yuan decided to pick up the Ten Thousand Ghost Blades technique.

Of course, there were still many more techniques that he could choose from, so he continued looking through all available techniques.

In the end, Yuan couldn't find another technique that was more interesting than the Ten Thousand Ghost Blades, so he decided to just save his free techniques for another time.

"Have you found any suitable techniques yet?" Yuan asked Chu Liuxiang after returning to them.

"I have about ten more techniques to go through, but I found two that I am interested in. I'll see which one I like better later," she said.

Yuan nodded his head and waited for her to finish.

Sometime later, Chu Liuxiang placed all of the techniques that she wasn't interested in aside to look at the two techniques that she found interesting.

"I need some advice on which technique I should get." Chu Liuxiang said to them.

"The first technique is called Everlasting Ice Field. It is an area of effect technique that can slow and even immobilize my opponents."

"The second technique is called Glacial Ice Dragon. I can create an ice dragon using my internal energy and attack my enemies with it. They're

both Heaven-rank techniques, too. I really like both of them, making it difficult for me to decide..."

Yuan smiled and said, "Do you even need to decide? If you like both of them, just take both."

"Really? You don't mind?"

"I still have 14 free techniques, 12 if we count yours. That's more than enough even if I give a free technique to everyone within the faction." Yuan nodded.

"Thank you, Yuan!" Chu Liuxiang was all smiles at this moment.

"The most important thing is that you have something to protect yourself. Anyways, now that we have our techniques, are we ready to leave?"

Everyone there nodded.

After returning to the first floor, Yuan handed the young man the three techniques.

"One Divine-rank and two Heaven-rank techniques. Give me a moment to log it down."

The young man handed the techniques back to them a few moments later.

"You're all set. If you need anything else, just ask."

"That's it?" Chu Liuxiang was dumbfounded by how easy it was to acquire such powerful techniques.

Min Li was also speechless. The Min Family would've needed to shell out tens of thousands of spirit stones for a single Heaven-rank technique, yet Yuan received 2 for free, not even mentioning the Divine-rank technique.

'Just what kind of background does he really have?' Min Li thought to herself.

Yuan and the others left the Myriad of Techniques shortly after receiving their new techniques.

"What now?" Chu Liuxiang asked.

"I am going to find an Array Master who can help me unseal the spatial rings and storage pouches that I picked up from the Gu Family," said Yuan.

"Young Master, why don't you do it yourself? You learned how to use arrays during one of the trials in the Stairway to Heaven, right? It will not only be much cheaper, it will also be much more convenient for you." Feng Yuxiang suggested.

"You're right... But where do I learn how to do something like that? I only know a few basic arrays from the book Huang Xiao Li gave me."

"There should be an Array Masters' Association somewhere in this city or another city. You can pay them to teach you arrays, or you can simply buy array techniques from them."

"Alright, let's ask around."

Thus, they began asking the pedestrians there.

Luckily for them, they found someone who had the information they wanted within minutes.

"The Array Masters' Association cannot be found in this city, but if you go to South Wing City, you will find them."

"Thank you for this information."

Now that they have this information, they need to head to this South Wing City.

Unfortunately, neither of them knew where to go, so they went to a nearby general store to buy a map of Spirit Heaven.

"This is a map? People really like putting information inside jade slips, huh." Yuan looked at the jade slip in his hand and realized this fact.

"Well, they're convenient since you can fit a lot of information inside a jade slip, kind of like spatial rings." Feng Yuxiang said.

"How does it even work? Putting information inside this small thing." Yuan asked.

"I'm not exactly sure, but the inside of that jade slip has its own dimension, sort of like a spatial ring, but you cannot put anything physical inside, so they put information that can only be seen if you are cultivators."

Yuan nodded, "I think I understand. Anyway, I don't really know how to read maps, so here you go."

He handed the map to Feng Yuxiang.

After taking a moment to study the map, Feng Yuxiang said, "Okay, I know where to go."

They left the city shortly after.

Since neither Min Li nor Chu Liuxiang could fly, Yuan carried them using his Qi Manipulation.

"Are flying treasures expensive? I am thinking about buying a few so that Meixiu, Lulu, and the others can also fly by themselves." Yuan asked as they traveled.

"It really depends on what type of flying treasures you want. But if you ask me, while they are definitely not cheap, they should be affordable for you, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Alright. I am going to look at them after I sell the Blood Sect's treasures." Yuan nodded.

About four hours later, Feng Yuxiang stopped moving.

"We have arrived at South Wing City, Young Master."

"That tall building must be the Array Masters' Association. I can see their array symbols all the way from here." Yuan mumbled.

Even though the building itself didn't look that conspicuous, it was more than obvious to someone like Yuan, who can see array symbols.

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Chapter 706 - Array Masters Association

Chapter 706 - Array Masters' Association

"So this is the Array Masters' Association... The building is a lot more ordinary than it looks from afar." Yuan was used to seeing extravagant and luxurious buildings, so he was a little surprised to see the Array Masters' Association looking so plain.

"Let's go inside, shall we?"

Upon entering the building, Yuan could see a long line that snaked around the first floor, taking up half of the floor's space. At glance, these people appeared to be waiting to buy something from the front desk, but they were all given a piece of paper before getting sent to the second floor.

Yuan looked around to find someone that appeared to work there and approached him.

"Hello, where can I buy array techniques?"

"You mean array combinations? Are you an Array Master?" The man asked him.

"Yes, I know a few arrays." Yuan nodded.

"Just because you know a few arrays doesn't make you an Array Master, kid." The man sneered, and he continued, "In order to be officially considered an Array Master, you must pass the Array Master Assessment. Only when you have the badge of an official Array Master can you buy array combinations from our Array Masters' Association."

"So I have to join the association before I can purchase array combinations?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"What's the difference between this and joining a sect for their techniques?"

"I think you're misunderstanding something. We're not recruiting you to join us. The Array Masters' Association has the authority to give others the identification of an Array Master. You can sign up to join us if you wish, but it's not a requirement. There are many Array Masters out there that aren't part of our association, and there is no punishment for not wanting to join us."

"However, if you don't take the assessment and become an official Array Master, you're not considered a real Array Master, and most places that sell array combinations require you to be an official Array Master."

"Is that so... Then where do I sign up for this Array Master Assessment?" Yuan then asked.

The man pointed at the long queue in the store.

"I figured..." Yuan sighed.

"Well, I am going to take this assessment. You guys don't have to wait with me if you don't want to." He said to Chu Liuxiang and the others.

"Where are we going to go? We have nowhere else to go. But even if I do, I'd rather stay here with you." Chu Liuxiang shrugged.

"Then I am going to rest for a bit. Call me if you need me, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang said before turning into a ball of flame and entering his body.

"It's a little bit crowded here, so I will also rest for now." Lan Yingying said as she turned into a bracelet.

Only Xiao Hua, Chu Liuxiang, and Min Li remained.

Thus, they began waiting in the queue.

As they waited, Yuan would notice the people coming back down from the upper floors, and most of them had disappointed looks on their faces.

Clearly, they went upstairs to take the assessment.

And within the hour they waited, Yuan counted 22 people, but only 2 of them appeared to be happy with their result.

'The assessment is probably going to be difficult, especially for someone like me, who learned about arrays only a week ago...' Yuan sighed inwardly.

Once they reached the front, the middle-aged man sitting behind the desk asked him, "What's your name? And how old are you?"

"Yuan, 18 years old."

"Cultivation?"

"Second Level Spirit Lord."

"..."

The middle-aged man looked up and stared at Yuan with a look of disbelief on his face.

However, he didn't immediately believe Yuan's words, so he had to check himself using his divine sense to probe Yuan's aura.

'What the fuck!? He's really a Spirit Lord! And he's only 18 years old? Who is this monster?!' The middle-aged man cried inwardly after confirming Yuan's claims as a Spirit Lord.

"A-And how long have you studied arrays?" He asked after a moment of silence.

"Not long. It's probably been a week since I learned about arrays," said Yuan.

"A week...?"

If it were not for Yuan's cultivation base being higher than his own, the middle-aged man would've cursed him out loud before kicking him out of the building.

After all, there was simply no way for someone to become an Array Master after studying arrays for a week. If that was possible, everybody would be an Array Master by now.

"Anyways... Take this paper and go to the second floor for your assessment."

"Thank you."

Yuan accepted the paper and began making his way upstairs.

The middle-aged man shook his head after Yuan left. If it weren't so risky to kick Yuan out because of his talents and mysterious background, he would've done so without a heartbeat.

'Whatever. He's no longer my problem.'

Meanwhile, Yuan had to stand in line again because there was another line for assessments.

Moreover, the line seemed to be moving at a much slower pace.

After two hours of painful waiting, they finally reached the front of the line.

Five more minutes later, the door in front of them opened, and a young woman came running out, her eyes pouring with tears.

"Next."

An aloof voice resounded the next moment, and Yuan entered the door with the others following behind him.

Inside the room was a long table with three people sitting behind— a stubborn-looking old man, a handsome man, and a beautiful but bored-looking woman.

"Boy, where do you think you are? This isn't the place for you to show off your girlfriends." The handsome man said to him when he saw the beauties following him.

"We'll wait for you outside..." Chu Liuxiang said to him before leaving the room, followed by Min Li and Xiao Hua.

"Now then, let us see your paper."

Yuan approached the table and handed them his paper.

The three judges' eyes widened with shock when they saw Yuan's cultivation base.

'Spirit Lord at 18 years old? No wonder why he's surrounded by beauties!' The handsome man cried inwardly.

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Chapter 707 - Array Master Assessment

The three judges were no doubt shocked about Yuan's cultivation base at his age. However, when they continued to read the paper and saw that he only has a week of experience in arrays, they raised their eyebrows.

"Is this correct? You've only been studying arrays for about a week?" The beautiful woman asked him, no longer looking so bored.

"That's correct." Yuan confirmed in a calm manner.

The three judges looked at him with dumbfounded faces.

Just who is this kid? How dare he come to the Array Masters' Association when he's just a beginner? Is he mocking them?

"You know, even the most talented Array Master in the Spirit Heaven in the last 500 years had to study for nine full months before he could become an official Array Master, and you're already trying to become one a week after you started studying? Although I like ambitious men, you're way over your head with this one." The beautiful woman said.

"As a fellow Spirit Lord, I don't want to be too harsh on you, but you're mocking us— all of the Array Masters by coming here today." The handsome man said.

After a moment of silence, the old man laughed, "What's the harm in letting him try? I'm sure it'll be more entertaining than the last couple hundred entries."

"Are you sure, Senior Huang? It will definitely be a waste of time." The handsome man said.

'Huang...?' Yuan raised his eyebrows upon hearing this familiar surname. Surely, it must be a coincidence, right?

"It's fine. We have nothing but time. Let's see... Yuan. The Array Master assessment will consist of three separate tests. The first one will test your ability to memorize and draw array symbols. The second test will test the speed you can combine the array symbols and activate it. As for the last test, we will test the strength of your array."

"Do you have any questions?"

Seeing Yuan shake his head, Senior Huang nodded and said, "Good. Then let's start the assessment. For the first test, I want you to create as much of the 10,000 basic array symbols as you can in 5 minutes. Every symbol you create must be unique and cannot be repeated."

"You will need at least 3,000 proper array symbols to be considered passing."

Yuan nodded and closed his eyes to recall all 10,000 basic symbols inside his head.

Once he was ready, he began creating the array symbols at a ludicrous speed.

Dozens of array symbols flew out of his palm every second, quickly filling the room with perfectly drawn array symbols.

"This motherfucker..." The handsome man subconsciously cursed out loud when he saw how perfect the array symbols were, not to mention how quickly they were being created.

Although many Array Masters, even amateur Array Masters, can create array symbols at the speed Yuan was making them, they would not be able

to create array symbols with quality that can match the ones Yuan was creating even if they were given all the time in the world.

Five minutes passed in the blink of an eye for the judges when they were absorbed by Yuan's beautiful array symbols, which is an incredible feat, considering that most examinees are disqualified before they can even use up all 5 minutes.

In the end, Yuan had only managed to create 9,000 array symbols before the time was up, meaning that he created around 30 array symbols every second, which is already faster than what most Array Masters can achieve after many years of practice.

And out of 9,000 of these array symbols, all of them have passed the quality check. In fact, they were the most beautiful array symbols that these judges have seen in a very long time.

"Did I pass the first test?" Yuan asked them when none of them spoke even after 5 minutes had passed.

'T-This bastard is definitely mocking us! There's no way that he'd only been studying arrays for a week!' The handsome man gritted his teeth in anger.

The other two judges also doubted Yuan's claims since it would be ludicrous that he can create such flawless array symbols after studying arrays for a week.

However, none of them said anything to Yuan, and they continued the test.

"You passed the first test..." Senior Huang said in a stiff voice, and he continued, "For the second test, we will give you three array combinations for you to do for yourself. In order to pass this test, two of your three array combinations must activate properly. Even if you can create array symbols flawlessly, combining them is a different story."

"Let us know when you're ready to begin."

"I am ready." Yuan immediately said.

"Good, then I will start first."

Senior Huang proceeded to create an array combination that consisted of a little over 150 symbols.

The beautiful woman went next, and her array combination consisted of around 120 array symbols.

The handsome man was last.

'If you think you can mock us and get away with it, then you're gravely mistaken!' He sneered inwardly.

The handsome man proceeded to create his array combination with around 30 array symbols, which is much lower than the others, but the other two judges frowned when they saw his array combination.

'This idiot is using level 3 array symbols in an assessment meant for entry-level Array Masters...' Senior Huang sighed inwardly.

Just like every other profession in the cultivation world, Array Masters also have a hierarchy system to separate the inexperienced from the experienced.

Array Masters are separated into 9 different levels with level 1 Array Masters being the lowest in the hierarchy, and the higher level the array symbol, the more difficult they are to create and combine.

The judges are supposed to use only level 1 array symbols for the Array Master assessment, but after feeling ridiculed by Yuan's results in the first test, the handsome man decided to take matters into his own hand by upping the difficulty, as he believed that Yuan wasn't the beginner that he claims to be.

Chapter 708 - Level 3 Array Symbols

The other two judges realized what the handsome man was trying to do, but they didn't say anything, as they also wanted to see how Yuan would handle this situation.

'Will he be able to create a level 3 formation?' Senior Huang wondered inwardly as Yuan took his time analyzing the array combinations.

'I don't recognize any of those array symbols...' Yuan stared at the handsome man's array combination with a pondering expression.

He was certain that he didn't miss any of the basic array symbols from Huang Xiao Li's manuals.

However, the handsome man had created array symbols that he didn't recognize, and they appear more complex than the basic symbols.

'They must be more advanced array symbols that I haven't learned yet... How troublesome...' Yuan did not even think for a second that the handsome man was trying to ridicule him by increasing the assessment's difficulty. He just thought it was part of the assessment and didn't think much about it.

'Let's just deal with the other two first before I try the difficult one. I only need two out of three to pass this test, anyway.'

With that in mind, Yuan ignored the handsome man's array combination and focused on the other two.

And within minutes, he figured how they were combined and what array symbols were used.

Yuan started with the beautiful woman's array combination. He first created the array symbols before combining them into a fully functional array.

"Pass." The beautiful woman gave her judgement after seeing the results.

He moved onto Senior Huang's array combination next, and although it was harder than the last array combination, he still managed to crack it and understand everything about it in just a few minutes.

A few moments later, Yuan replicated Senior Huang's array combination and showed it to him.

"It's also a pass from me." Senior Huang said, and he continued, "You have already passed the second test, but if you wish to try and replicate the third one, you may go ahead and do so. Personally, I want to see you try."

Yuan nodded and turned to look at the last array combination. Even if Senior Huang hadn't mentioned it, he would've still tried to solve it.

'Arrays are just like puzzles. Once assembled, you have to figure out what array symbols they used and how they combined it. 30 array symbols can have over a billion possible combinations, and each of these billion combinations can be considered a unique array.' Yuan recalled the manuals he read about arrays.

'Although I don't know any of these array symbols, as long as I can figure out their combination pattern, I should be able to replicate the array.'

And for the next ten minutes, Yuan would stare intensely at the handsome man's array combination, almost like he was trying to stare a hole into it.

If it was an ordinary test, the judges would've disqualified him for taking so much time, but since the handsome man used level 3 array symbols, it was only fair that they be patient while Yuan tried to solve the array combination.

The judges were prepared to sit there for an entire hour to see if Yuan could solve it, but after waiting for 15 minutes, Yuan began moving his fingers.

Since he has never seen these array symbols before, he could not create them as fast as the basic symbols.

It took almost two whole seconds for Yuan to create a single array symbol, but when he finished, it would come out as flawlessly as the basic array symbols.

'Impossible...' The judges' eyes widened with surprise when Yuan completed his first array symbol.

Even if Yuan lied about his experiences, it was almost certain to the judges that Yuan's age was as he claimed, and regardless of his situation, any 18-year-old that can create level 3 array symbols is considered a top array prodigy.

After another two seconds, Yuan created his second array symbol... then his third... fourth... and so on.

Senior Huang and the beautiful woman's excitement grew with each array symbol, but it was the complete opposite for the handsome man.

If word gets out that he tried to mock a junior with level 3 array symbols but backfired in the end, he would become a laughing stock in the Array Masters' Association.

And to make matters worse for him, Yuan's level 3 array symbols were also much more precise and refined than his own.

'I cannot let him finish the array combination!' The handsome man cried inwardly.

Right as Yuan finished making the 27th array symbol, the handsome man suddenly slammed the table while shouting, "Stop!"

Yuan was startled by the sudden outburst and immediately lost his concentration.

All 27 array symbols that he'd created disappeared the moment his concentration was disturbed.

When Senior Huang and the beautiful woman saw the flawless array symbols disappear before their very eyes, they felt some pain in their heart. As Array Masters, they respected and admired the art of array symbols, and when such perfect array symbols disappear like that, it was akin to an artist watching a masterpiece being destroyed before their very eyes.

Bang!

The door suddenly flew open, and a small figure appeared in front of Yuan the next moment.

"Brother Yuan, are you okay?" Xiao Hua asked him.

"Y-Yes, I am fine." He nodded in a dazed manner.

The guards outside also entered the room shortly after.

"Master Zeng! What was that about?!" The beautiful woman quickly shifted her angry gaze at the handsome man for ruining such a spectacular show.

The handsome man immediately responded, "I-I thought I saw something wrong with the 28th array symbol, and I was worried that it might explode on us, so I subconsciously shouted for him to stop."

Senior Huang silently shook his head, as he was fully aware of the handsome man's lies.

He then turned to the guards and said, "It was just a misunderstanding. You can leave us alone now."

The guards bowed to them before leaving the room.

"Let's just continue to the final test, shall we?" Senior Huang asked Yuan a moment later.

"Okay." He nodded.

"Xiao Hua, I am fine. You can go back outside."

However, Xiao Hua seemed reluctant to leave, and she was staring at the handsome man with narrowed eyes, seemingly in deep thoughts.

"It's okay. Your friend can stay here." Senior Huang suddenly said.

"I understand. Thank you, Senior.." Yuan bowed to him.

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Chapter 709 - Officially Becoming An Array Master

"Then let us continue to the third and final test. For the third test, we simply need you to create an array—the stronger the better, and we will test its strength." Senior Huang said to him.

Yuan nodded and created a confinement array a few seconds later.

"Impressive..." Senior Huang muttered in a dazed voice, as he has never seen such a powerful basic array before.

"Is this really a level 1 array? Even level 2 arrays would not be able to contest against this..." The beautiful woman mumbled to herself as she inspected the array with great focus.

The handsome man, however, remained seated in his chair behind the table, almost like he had no intention of even looking at the array.

Yuan figured that it was because he could see the array from that distance, so he didn't need to look at it closely.

Sometime later, the other judges returned to their seat with a look of fascination on their faces, looking like their views on this world had been broadened.

"Ahem!" Senior Huang cleared his throat before speaking, "Yuan... You have passed the assessment. I don't think any of us would deny someone of your talents as an Array Master. In fact, it would be disingenuous if we made you a level 1 Array Master."

"Therefore, I suggest that we give you an advance promotion to a level 2 Array Master. Normally, if you want to raise your level, you would need another assessment, but you have proven yourself more than worthy of being a level 1 Array Master today."

"If you don't agree with my decision, let me hear your reasons, fellow Masters." Senior Huang turned to look at the other two judges.

"No, I totally agree with you, Master Huang. If he doesn't deserve being a level 2 Array Master, then nobody should be qualified to be one. I would even argue that you qualify as a level 3 Array Master based on your mastery over creating array symbols alone, but your speed is a little too slow even for an average level 3 Array Master, and we need more than just the three of us to promote you to a level 3 Array Master."

They turned to look at Master Zeng, who had been silent this entire time, and he continued to remain silent.

"Silence often means you have no objections, so I will go ahead and say congratulations, Array Master Yuan, you have passed the assessment and become a level 2 Array Master." Senior Huang said to him.

"Congratulations, Yuan." The beautiful woman also congratulated him.

And she continued, "I have been wondering for a while now, but exactly how long have you been studying arrays? Surely, you didn't study arrays for only a week to have such results. Now that we're aware of your capabilities, you can stop joking with us and just tell us the truth."

Senior Huang nodded his head, "I would also like to know the truth. Even if you started learning when you were 10, it is still an incredible achievement to become a level 2 Array Master at the age of 18."

A weird smile appeared on Yuan's face as he said, "But I'm not joking... I really only started learning arrays around a week ago. I only know of the 10,000 basic symbols and the basics to combining array symbols."

The entire room turned dead silent.

"Are you telling me that you don't know any level 2 or level 3 array symbols? T-Then how did you create those level 3 array symbols? There's no way someone with only one week of experience can do such a thing!" The beautiful woman exclaimed.

"Level 3 array symbols? Sorry, but I don't know what those are." Yuan shook his head.

"Arrays are separated into 9 different levels depending on their difficulty, and the 10,000 basic array symbols are level 1 array symbols—the least complex array symbols and also the easiest to learn. Intermediate array symbols are level 2, advanced symbols are level 3, and so on... What Master Zeng created during the 2nd test are level 3 array symbols." Senior Huang explained to him.

"Is that so... No wonder why I didn't know any of those array symbols. Turns out that they were not part of the 10,000 basic array symbols. Anyways, I merely copied the array symbols. Although they're definitely much more complex than level 1 array symbols, they still function the same, so as long as I can trace the symbols, I can create them." Yuan said.

"Y-You traced them?" Senior Huang stared at him with a shocked face.

How can someone treat array symbols as though they are merely words on a paper? Even if one can trace level 3 symbols, activating them is a different story!

If arrays were as simple as words on a paper, everybody would be a level 3 Array Master and above!

"So you're telling me that you really have only one week of experience as an Array Master?" The beautiful woman asked him in a dumbfounded voice.

Yuan nodded his head calmly.

"W-Who is your Master? Where did you learn about arrays?" She continued to ask.

"A friend of mine explained the basics to me, but I learned arrays mostly through the manuals that she gave me. The Body Shielding Array, 10,000 Array Symbols, and Guide to Combining Array Symbols. Those were the manuals she gave me to study."

Senior Huang nearly fell out of his chair from shock when he heard the names of the manuals.

'These are all basic manuals for complete beginners who have no experience in arrays! Even the Body Shielding Array is one of the most common array combinations out there! He's definitely screwing with us!' Senior Huang cried inwardly.

Neither Senior Huang or the beautiful woman believed Yuan's words for a second.. They speculated that he was probably from a hidden family of renowned Array Masters, hence why he was reluctant to tell them the truth.

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Chapter 710 - Level 2 Array Master

Chapter 710: Level 2 Array Master

“Here, this is your badge. As long as you have this, you can purchase array combinations from any store and treat any Array Masters’ Association as though it’s your second home.”

Senior Huang handed Yuan a green badge.

Ding!

<You have acquired the title ‘Level 1 Array Master’>

<You have acquired the title ‘Level 2 Array Master’>

“There’s an array inside this badge?” Yuan could immediately tell upon touching it.

“That’s right. Without the array, the badge is just a useless piece of metal, and it makes it harder to be replicated by others who want to profit from it.” Senior Huang nodded.

The beautiful woman added, “Being an Array Master is more prestigious than one might think since it’s not an easy profession. Some might argue that it’s even more difficult than being an Alchemist, so there are many people who pretend to be an Array Master to receive benefits that they don’t deserve.”

“Therefore, you need to make sure that you don’t lose that badge. If you happen to lose that badge, you will need to partake in another assessment

because we have no proof that you're an Array Master."

Yuan nodded, "I will keep the badge safe."

"Before you leave, Yuan." Senior Huang suddenly said, "Do you have any intentions of joining the Array Masters' Association? There are many benefits in joining us, such as free array combinations and being taught by the best of the best Array Masters from around the Nine Heavens."

"The Nine Heavens?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"Yes. Did you think the Array Masters' Association only existed in this world? The Array Masters' Association is one of the biggest factions in the Nine Heavens, and we can be found in every single realm."

"I will keep that in mind. As for joining the Array Masters' Association, give me some time to think about it."

"Very well. If you ever decide to join us, just give us a visit— or any Array Masters' Association for that matter." Elder Huang nodded.

"Goodbye. Thank you for everything today." Yuan bowed to them before leaving the room with Xiao Hua.

Once they left, Senior Huang turned to look at Master Zeng and said, "You've been awfully quiet since the end of the 2nd test, and the way you acted today is not acceptable for someone of your stature. If that talented young man holds a grudge against the Array Masters' Association, it will be your fault, and that is what I will be telling the higher-ups if they ask."

However, Master Zeng remained silent.

"Master Zeng...? Are you okay? You're sweating awfully a lot..." It was at this moment Senior Huang and the other judge noticed that he was covered in sweat.

The chair he sat on was also starting to creak as his body began trembling.

“M-Master Zeng? What is happening to you? Do you need medical assistance?” They stared at him with frowns on their faces.

“N-No... I-I am fine...” He suddenly muttered in a low voice.

“What happened to you?” Senior Huang asked again.

Master Zeng closed his eyes and took a couple of deep breaths before speaking, “Someone was threatening me... No, multiple people threatened my life just now.”

“Huh? What are you talking about?”

“You couldn’t sense it probably because it was directly at me, but I felt intense killing intent directed at me, and from multiple people as well. If I dared to move, I would’ve probably been killed on the spot.”

Senior Huang and the beautiful woman exchanged puzzled glances with each other. They couldn’t understand why someone would want to kill him.

The beautiful woman decided to ask, “Why would anybody want to kill you? And we were alone in this room except for Yuan. If he was threatening you with killing intent, we would’ve definitely noticed it.”

“It wasn’t him.” Master Zeng quickly shook his head.

“It was that person standing behind him— that little devil...”

“You mean that little girl? Master Zeng... I think you’re just exhausted. Go home and get some rest. We’ll handle the assessment.” The beautiful woman shook her head.

“You don’t understand! I can’t leave! They are still inside the building! I cannot leave until they leave!” Master Zeng shouted.

Senior Huang was stumped by his reaction. They have never seen him this afraid before. Furthermore, he was a Spirit Lord. Even if the little girl was staring at him with killing intent, it shouldn’t affect him.

“Do whatever you want, but we still have many people waiting to be assessed.” Senior Huang said, and he called in the next examinee a moment later.

Meanwhile, as they walked back downstairs, Xiao Hua said, “Brother Yuan, that man in the room showed a hint of killing intent towards you.”

“Eh? Really? I didn’t notice it, probably because I was so focused on the tests.”

“Don’t worry, Xiao Hua made sure that he couldn’t do anything funny.”

“Is that why you refused to leave the room? Thank you, Xiao Hua.”

“Un.” She nodded with a satisfied face.

Back on the first floor, Yuan returned to the man that he first spoke to when he came to this place.

“I am now an official Array Master. Where can I buy array combinations?”

“Huh...?” The man stared at him with widened eyes.

Yuan retrieved the green badge and showed it to the man.

“L-Level 2 Array Master?! I thought you said you weren’t one!” The man exclaimed.

He has never seen someone skip level 1 and become a level 2 Array Master right after the Array Masters’ Association, so he thought that Yuan was already an Array Master, and he just finished his promotion examination.

Yuan merely shrugged his shoulders.

“...”

After a moment of silence, the man pointed to the ceiling and said, “You can buy array combinations on the third floor.”

“Thank you.”

Yuan and the others began making their way back up the staircase.

A few minutes later, they arrived on the third floor.

“Welcome to the Array Masters’ Association. Are you an Array Master?” A middle-aged woman greeted them.

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Chapter 711 - Unsealing Spatial Rings

Chapter 711: Unsealing Spatial Rings

“Yes, I am. Here’s my badge.” Yuan showed her the Array Master’s badge.

“Thank you very much, Senior Array Master. If you’re looking for a specific array combination or anything specific, just let me know.”

Yuan then said, “Then I would like an array combination for sealed spatial rings and storage pouches.”

“Just for confirmation, arrays that remove sealed spatial rings and storage pouches, is that correct?” She asked.

“Yes, that’s right.”

“I understand. Please follow me.”

Yuan and the others followed this woman to a counter. She picked out a couple of manuals from under the desk and laid them out before him.

“Are all of these...?” Yuan raised his eyebrows, as he didn’t expect there to be so many array combinations for the same purpose.

“All of these array combinations are for unsealing spatial rings and storage pouches, but they all have different strengths. One can have a higher chance of success while another one can be easier to use. It all depends on the array combination.”

“Which of these have the highest success rate?” Yuan asked.

“That would be this one— the Absolute Unsealing Array, but it’s a level 3 array combination.”

Since Yuan is only a level 2 Array Master, he would not be able to use the level 3 array combination, so it wouldn’t make sense for him to buy it.

“Okay, I will take that. And do you also have manuals for level 2 and level 3 array symbols?”

“Of course. Give me a moment...”

The woman reached under the desk for two more manuals.

“7,000 Intermediate Array Symbols and 5,000 Advanced Array Symbols.” Yuan read the titles, which surprised him a little, as he’d expected the number of array symbols to go up the more difficult they got.

“How much for these three manuals?” Yuan asked the woman a moment later.

“That would be Fifteen million gold, but since you’re a Level 2 Array Master, you have a 25 percent discount when buying from the Array Masters’ Association. The new total will be 11,250,000 gold coins.”

“E-Eleven million gold coins even with a discount...?” Yuan was speechless. He didn’t think array combinations were this expensive.

“Brother Yuan, here.” Xiao Hua suddenly handed him a storage pouch.

“What is this?” He asked.

“It’s the money that we’ve saved from the auction house. There should be more than enough money to buy the manuals,” she said.

Yuan’s eyes flickered with excitement.

“I almost forgot about this money! Are you sure, Xiao Hua? The money is still technically yours.”

She nodded, “Anything that helps Brother Yuan is worth it.”

“Thank you, Xiao Hua.”

Yuan proceeded to pay for the three manuals using the money they’d earned from selling Xiao Hua’s Heaven-grade treasure at some auction house.

“Here is your purchase. Thank you for doing business with us, Senior Array Master.” The woman offered the manuals to him with her head lowered.

After accepting the manuals, Yuan left the Array Masters’ Association and went to rent out a new hotel room in the city.

“I am going to spend a few days studying these manuals. You guys can do whatever until then.” Yuan said to the others.

“Okay. I am also going to study the techniques I just got.” Chu Liuxiang said.

“I’m going to cultivate. If you need me, don’t hesitate to call for me.” Min Li said before entering one of the four rooms in that hotel room.

Chu Liuxiang also went into her own room.

Yuan remained in the living room, and he placed the three manuals on the table before him.

“I should probably start with the level 2 array symbols...”

Thus, Yuan began flipping through the manual, spending the rest of today and tomorrow memorizing all 7,000 level 2 array symbols.

Two days later, Yuan placed the level 2 array symbols to the side and began studying level 3 array symbols.

Even though there were less array symbols in total compared to the other 2, it took Yuan almost four days to completely memorize all 5,000 level 3 array symbols.

Of course, four days may seem like a lot of time, but for ordinary Array Masters, it would take them years if not decades to achieve the same results.

After memorizing all array symbols up to level 3, Yuan moved onto the Absolute Unsealing Array.

A couple of minutes later, he understood everything.

“Before I use this array on the Gu Family’s spatial rings, I want to experiment it on other spatial rings just in case I mess up. Do any of you have any unused spatial rings or storage pouches?” Yuan asked them.

“I have a couple, Young Master.”

Feng Yuxiang appeared beside him with a dozen storage pouches and six spatial rings.

“They should all have my seal on it. They are also empty, so you don’t have to worry about destroying them,” she said.

“Thank you... but why do you have so many of these? People normally only carry one or two, right?”

“I have a lot of treasures to store because of my business. That’s all.”

“I see...”

Yuan began inspecting the spatial rings and storage pouches the next moment.

Half a minute later, Yuan began creating level 3 array symbols in the air.

He created exactly 50 level 3 array symbols, which he combined into a complete array, before sending it directly inside Feng Yuxiang’s spatial ring.

Yuan inspected the spatial ring again afterward, and sure enough, Feng Yuxiang’s aura that was present just moments ago was no longer there, almost as though it’d vanished.

“I think I succeeded. Can you take a look at it for me?” Yuan handed the spatial ring back to Feng Yuxiang.

She nodded with a smile, “Yes, good job, Young Master. You have erased my seal perfectly.”

“Great. Then can you reseal it again so that I can continue practicing until I am confident? I want to be absolutely certain that I can open them perfectly.”

“Most certainly, Young Master.” Feng Yuxiang said as she sealed the spatial ring with her spiritual energy.

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Chapter 712 - Suddenly Wealthy

Chapter 712: Suddenly Wealthy

After spending an entire day unsealing Feng Yuxiang's spatial rings and storage pouches, Yuan was finally confident enough to work on the Gu Family's spatial rings.

"You can do it, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang cheered him from the side.

Yuan nodded and retrieved Gu Tao's spatial ring. He has decided to unseal this one first, leaving Patriarch Gu's spatial rings for last.

"Gu Tao was only a Spirit Warrior, so his seal isn't particularly strong..."

In just a couple of minutes, Yuan had managed to unsealed Gu Tao's spatial ring.

"Wow, there's a bunch of spirit stones and monster cores inside this spatial ring."

Yuan was immediately impressed by Gu Tao's rich spatial ring.

"There's about 1,000 spirit stones in here that are worth 10 million gold, a couple dozen Spirit Warrior monster cores, an Earth-grade treasure, and some pills..."

Besides the spirit stones, pretty much everything inside Gu Tao's spatial ring was worthless to him, who was already a Spirit Lord.

'10 million gold... This is more than I'd anticipated, so I am satisfied with the results. As for the other stuff... I don't think they will sell for much, so I

will just save it for now. Maybe I can even give it to Wang Ming and the others.'

"Let's move onto Patriarch Gu's spatial ring now."

Patriarch Gu had two spatial rings and one storage pouch.

"Seeing how he acted when I took this from him, this spatial ring should have a fortune inside." Yuan mumbled to himself before placing the spatial ring to the side, saving the best for last.

'Hmm... This is definitely going to be a lot harder than unsealing Gu Tao's spatial ring since he was a Spirit Grandmaster. However, Feng Feng is also a Spirit Grandmaster, and she's stronger than him, so I shouldn't have any problems with it.'

While Yuan focused on unsealing the spatial rings, Feng Yuxiang and Xiao Hua watched from the side.

"No matter what he does, the Young Master is always talented at it. This makes me want to find something that he's not good at. Do you have any idea what he might be bad at, Xiao Hua?" Feng Yuxiang asked her.

Xiao Hua silently shook her head.

"Then let me think... He's good with weapons and instruments... He became a level 2 Array Master after a week of studying... He can learn techniques as natural as breathing... His cultivation talents... let's not even mention it..."

"I cannot think of anything— Actually... What about Alchemy? I have never seen the Young Master do alchemy before. What about you?"

"No."

"Even though it's not really good to walk multiple paths at the same time, I kind of want to see how the Young Master will perform in the field of Alchemy. In terms of reputation, I'd say they're even more important and useful than arrays."

“Got it!” Yuan suddenly released a shout of excitement.

Feng Yuxiang and Xiao Hua turned to look at Yuan, who was already looking inside the spatial ring.

“Wow! As expected of the Patriarch of a Legacy Family! His personal spatial ring has a ton of treasures! There are around 5,000 spirit stones, a Heaven-grade treasure, many Spirit Master monster cores, pills, and some other stuff!”

“Feng Feng, what kind of treasures are these?” Yuan retrieved a couple of objects and showed it to her.

“This one over here is a live-saving treasure. This one as well. As for this one, it’s a flying treasure.” Feng Yuxiang explained as she pointed at each of the treasures.

“I see... How much could I earn if I sell all of these treasures? Oh, except the flying treasure. I am going to keep that.”

Feng Yuxiang pondered for a moment before speaking, “Well, not including the spirit stones, you can sell these treasures at a minimum of 50 million gold, but if we take it to an auction house, we can potentially double that amount.”

Yuan’s eyes immediately flickered with excitement.

“Great! Then we’ll sell these!”

Feng Yuxiang then said, “If you’d like, I would be more than happy to help you sell the treasures in an auction house. Not only can I tell the value of these treasures but I also know how to deal with auction houses.”

Yuan nodded without hesitation and handed her the spatial ring, “I will leave the treasures to you then.”

“I will immediately go and sell these now—”

“Wait a second, Feng Feng. Before you go, let me unseal the rest of this stuff.” Yuan quickly stopped her.

“I understand. Please take your time.”

Yuan immediately began working on the storage pouch, unsealing it a couple of minutes later.

“Heavens, there’s nothing but spirit stones in here! One thousand, two thousand... There’s a total of 10,000 spirit stones in here! That’s worth 100 million gold! I am rich! Ahahaha!”

Yuan started laughing out loud after realizing that he was suddenly rich.

Of course, that amount of gold really isn’t much, especially if they consider how much his own treasures were worth, but Xiao Hua and Feng Yuxiang remained silent so that Yuan could enjoy the moment.

After he calmed down, Yuan turned to look at Patriatch Gu’s last spatial ring.

“Nah, let’s take a look at what I obtained from the Blood Sect first since I don’t have to unseal those.”

Thus, Yuan began looking through the spatial rings and storage pouches he’d obtained from looting the Blood Sect.

There were around 120 spatial rings and storage pouches combined, and it took Yuan almost two hours sorting through everything.

He took the spirit stones for himself and handed the treasures worth over 100,000 gold to Feng Yuxiang to sell in an auction later.

As for the treasures worth less than 100,000 golds and the useful ones, he decided to keep them so that he could give them to the members of his faction later.

“What should we do with these techniques? Should we also sell them?” Yuan asked Feng Yuxiang.

“If it’s not a taboo technique, then it should be safe.” She nodded.

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Chapter 713 - Destiny Seal

Chapter 713: Destiny Seal

“Taboo techniques? What is that? And how can I tell if a technique is taboo or not?” Yuan asked.

“Can I see the techniques?” Feng Yuxiang then asked.

“Here you go.” Yuan handed all of the Blood Sect’s techniques to her.

Feng Yuxiang looked at each of them and separated them into two different piles.

“The techniques on the right are normal techniques while the ones on the left are taboo techniques. You can tell the difference based on their aura. Taboo techniques all have a sinister aura.” Feng Yuxiang said.

“All techniques considered taboo by the heavens will automatically have this sinister aura, so even if you copy it on a new piece of paper, it would still have a sinister aura. As for how the heavens decide which technique is taboo... I have no idea.”

“I see... So we cannot sell the taboo techniques, right?”

“Well, that is not entirely correct. There is nothing stopping you from selling taboo techniques, but most places will refuse to buy them, so you can only sell them in the black market, but that is not recommended, and you could offend the heavens by selling them.”

“If we can’t sell them, what can we do with them?”

Feng Yuxiang pondered for a moment and said, “The most logical thing is to destroy them so that they don’t spread around, as it could cause chaos if someone evil acquires them. All taboo techniques have a high chance of making those that cultivate them crazy, after all.”

“Okay, I will destroy them.”

And without hesitation, Yuan ripped the techniques into many pieces.

Ding!

<You have earned the title ‘Taboo Technique Destroyer’!>

“You can sell those techniques, Feng Feng. I would keep them since they’re useful, especially the Bloody Sword Strike, but I don’t want my friends to use a technique that has taken away so many innocent lives.”

“Don’t worry, Young Master. Most of these techniques are pretty trash. Even an Earth-rank technique is nothing for you, who can acquire Heaven-rank techniques as easy as candy.”

After handing Feng Yuxiang everything from the Blood Sect, Yuan continued to examine Lord Blood’s spatial ring.

“1,000 spirit stones and some pills... How can the sect master of the Blood Sect be so poor?” Yuan shook his head after looking inside.

“He probably hid his treasures away, unlike the Gu Family that likes to walk around with their wealth.” Feng Yuxiang shrugged.

“Whatever. Let’s open up the last spatial ring and see what’s inside.”

Yuan proceeded to take a moment to clear his mind.

Once he was prepared, he started making the array.

A few minutes later, Yuan unsealed Patriarch Gu’s spatial ring and took a look inside.

“Whoa!”

Yuan’s eyes immediately began glistening.

“What is inside, Young Master?” Feng Yuxiang was also interested in Patriarch Gu’s spatial ring.

“Here, let me dump it out.”

He proceeded to dump out everything inside the spatial ring onto the table before them.

Very quickly, a mountain of treasures with a profound aura was created.

“Hmm... Not bad.” Feng Yuxiang nodded with approval after seeing the treasures.

“How much would I get from selling these?” Yuan quickly asked.

“It’s hard to tell, but you should get a few billion gold coins at the very least.”

“A few billion?!” Yuan’s eyes widened with shock.

With this much gold, he should be set for a very long time!

“Let’s sell them all!” Yuan then said.

“Wait a moment, Young Master. Let me see the treasures closely...”

Feng Yuxiang picked up a random treasure and inspected it.

A few moments later, she placed it down and said, “Young Master, that treasure contains the Gu Family’s destiny seal. We won’t be able to sell it until we remove it.”

“Huh? Destiny seal? What is that? Is it any different from the seals on spatial rings?”

Feng Yuxiang shook her head, “They are completely different. Although they function somewhat similarly, destiny seals are much more powerful, and they have a lot more restrictions.”

“Destiny seals can only be created by powerful families in the Nine Heavens, and if they put one inside a treasure, that would restrict anyone that is not part of their family bloodline from using it. They are not only impossible to sell even in black markets, but the buyer will most likely report you to the Gu Family for a reward.”

After hearing Feng Yuxiang’s explanation, Yuan pondered for a moment before asking, “Since it’s a seal, I should be able to remove it using arrays, right?”

“Yes, you can, but arrays that can remove destiny seals are incredibly rare and expensive. Even if you sell all of the treasures here, you probably won’t be able to purchase one. However, that’s not even the most difficult part, as it’s even more difficult to find a seller.”

“Now let’s say you somehow managed to buy one... You will probably need to become a level 4 or 5 Array Master before you can use the array.”

“Then what should I do with these treasures?” Yuan pointed at the mountain of treasures on the table.

“We can only wait until you are able to break the destiny seal, or we can find someone who knows how to remove them...” Feng Yuxiang said.

“Do you know anyone like that?”

Feng Yuxiang began pondering.

“When I escaped from the upper heavens, I had spent a few years in each realm to prepare myself. During my time here, I learned of a guy named Jia Chong, who was rumored to know how to remove destiny seals.”

“Do you know where we can find him?”

“I don’t, but I know someone who does.” Feng Yuxiang smiled.

And she continued, “A famous information broker who knows pretty much everything within the Spirit Heaven. However, he’ll charge you a lot of money, so you need to prepare for it.”

Yuan nodded, “Okay. Can you help me sell the treasures that we can sell?”

“It would be my pleasure.” Feng Yuxiang nodded with an eager smile.

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Chapter 714 - Bright Night City

After organizing all of the treasures that she was going to sell, Feng Yuxiang prepared to leave to find an auction house.

“Young Master, I don’t know when I will be back, but I will do my best to return as swiftly as possible.”

“Wait, Feng Feng. Take Xiao Hua with you.” Yuan suddenly said to her.

“Brother Yuan?” Xiao Hua looked at him with a questioning gaze.

“Although Feng Feng is a peak Spirit Grandmaster, we’re no longer in the Lower Heavens where Spirit Grandmaster is the peak. There are many Spirit Lords and even Spirit Kings in this world, and I want to make sure that nothing happens to her when she’s out there. After all, she’s carrying a lot of treasure, which could attract bandits.”

“...Okay.” Xiao Hua nodded her head despite knowing very well that nobody could harm Feng Yuxiang, who is a Divine Beast, as she wanted Yuan to be free of worries.

“You don’t have to worry about me. I won’t be going anywhere until you return.” Yuan said to them.

“See you later, Brother Yuan.”

“Stay safe, Young Master!”

“I should be saying that to you.” Yuan smiled as he watched them leave the hotel.

After they left, Yuan retrieved the Ten Thousand Ghost Blades technique and started studying it.

Meanwhile, Feng Yuxiang and Xiao Hua left the city.

“The Young Master is very caring, don’t you think so too, Xiao Hua?” Feng Yuxiang said to her as they traveled in the sky.

“Even if I am a Spirit Grandmaster, I won’t die to any Spirit Lord or Spirit King because I am not an ordinary cultivator, but a Divine Beast.”

“That is just Brother Yuan’s nature. Even if you can’t die, he still wouldn’t like to see you hurt.”

“If only I’d met him sooner in the upper heavens, maybe I wouldn’t need to be cursed like this...” Feng Yuxiang sighed.

“Enough talking, phoenix. Let’s hurry up and sell these treasures so that I can return to Brother Yuan as soon as possible.” Xiao Hua said in a nonchalant voice.

“Yeah, yeah. We’ll have to take the teleportation device in the next city that we’ll arrive in if we continue traveling this direction.”

Xiao Hua didn’t say anything else and suddenly increased her flying speed.

Feng Yuxiang silently smiled and followed her without losing in speed. In fact, she was still casually following behind Xiao Hua.

As a phoenix, she is naturally superior when it comes to flying, even if she’s in her human form.

Many hours later, they arrived at this massive city that was still bustling with people despite it being past midnight.

“Xiao Hua, stop at that city. We’ve arrived.” Feng Yuxiang warned her as they approached this city.

They descended shortly after and began walking towards the city entrance.

“Welcome to the city that never sleeps— Bright Night City. This is one of the busiest and wealthiest cities in the Second Heaven. Money never stops flowing in this place, and it’s where most merchants and cultivators go to find rare or unique treasures. Of course, it is also home to one of the biggest auction house names in the Nine Heavens, the House of Riches.” Feng Yuxiang introduced the city to Xiao Hua, who wasn’t really interested.

“They have an auction at least once a week, so we should be able to sell our stuff quickly.”

After paying a fee at the entrance and doing a quick background check to make sure they weren’t criminals, they were allowed inside the city.

Once they were inside, Feng Yuxiang led Xiao Hua to the House of Riches, which was located in one of the wealthiest streets in the city and also had the largest building there.

Feng Yuxiang adjusted her clothes before walking into the building with a glamorous air around her that made people turn their heads and shift their gazes the moment she entered their view.

One glance at Feng Yuxiang and everybody there could tell that she was someone of importance— someone worth their attention and respect.

In less than a minute after entering the building and without needing to say a single word, Feng Yuxiang managed to capture the attention of the guests and workers in the House of Riches with her aura alone.

“Welcome to the House of Riches, Esteemed Guests. How can we assist you today?” A beautiful woman approached them shortly after.

Feng Yuxiang glanced at her and said in a calm and clear voice, “I am here to sell my treasures.”

“I understand. Please, follow me to the VIP room, where you can arrange an auction with one of our supervisors.”

Feng Yuxiang nodded and followed this woman to another room on the second floor.

“Our supervisor will be with you shortly. Please satisfy yourselves with our spiritual tea and snacks for the time being on that table there.”

Once the woman left, Feng Yuxiang and Xiao Hua sat on the soft couch and waited for this supervisor to show up.

Three minutes later, a middle-aged woman who emitted a profound aura entered the room.

Xiao Hua glanced at this woman, who was clearly a peak Spirit Lord.

“Hello, Esteemed Guests. I am Gu Xiulan, the manager of this House of Riches. I heard from one of my assistants that you would like to sell at our auction house. Rest assured, our House of Riches will not only guarantee you the lowest commission rates, but your treasure will also sell for the highest in our auction house out of all auction houses within this city and nearby cities.”

“That’s good to hear. The more money I get out of the treasures, the more pleased my Young Master will be.” Feng Yuxiang nodded calmly.

‘Y-Young Master? Someone of her quality is actually serving another person?’ Gu Xiulan was shocked to learn that Feng Yuxiang wasn’t actually in charge and that she was only a servant.

However, this information did not make Gu Xiulan look down on her. In fact, she became even more fearful as she imagined the kind of person that could tame a woman like Feng Yuxiang.

Even though this is their first meeting, Gu Xiulan could tell by her aura and demeanor alone that Feng Yuxiang was someone of high status and not someone to be trifled with, not to mention the little girl that was sitting beside her, who appeared to be even more dangerous.

Chapter 715 - House of Riches

Chapter 715: House of Riches

“Can you show me what you’re trying to sell?” Gu Xiulan asked them after a moment of silence.

Feng Yuxiang nodded and retrieved a treasure from her storage ring before placing it on the round table before them.

“T-This is...”

Gu Xiulan’s body trembled with shock upon seeing the treasure, and her eyes were wide with disbelief.

“This... Is this what I think it is...?” Gu Xiulan had to swallow her nervousness a couple of times before she could utter any words.

The House of Riches has existed for thousands of years, and being one of the most famous auction houses in this world, they have dealt with countless valuable and priceless treasures.

Gu Xiulan, while having worked at the House of Riches for only fifty years, has seen her fair share of valuable treasures, so there were not many treasures out that could excite her, much less shock her to such an extent.

However, seeing Feng Yuxiang’s treasure had shocked her so much that she forgot her position as the manager of the auction house.

“If you think this is the scale belonging to a Flood Dragon, then you are correct.” Feng Yuxiang smiled.

“How in heaven’s name did you acquire such a treasure? Flood Dragons are extremely rare, and they can only be found in the Fourth Heaven and above! Although I have never personally seen a Flood Dragon’s scale before, I have read about them, and according to its flawless surface that has no visible damages, this is a perfect scale!”

Flood Dragons are incredibly scarce and powerful magical beasts that belong to the dragon race, and they border between being a magical beast and a Divine Beast. Furthermore, most of them are born with a cultivation at Spirit Emperor, so many cultivators fear them.

“How I acquired it is none of your business. The question here is whether you want to sell this or not.”

“O-Of course!” Gu Xiulan immediately nodded her head. Even an idiot would not refuse to sell such a priceless treasure at their auction house.

“Good, but I have a few conditions. If you don’t accept these conditions, I will have to visit the next auction house.” Feng Yuxiang calmly said, as she was not worried about not being able to sell the Flood Dragon’s scale.

After all, any auction house that manages to sell such a priceless treasure would instantly become the most popular auction house for the next decade, even century, regardless of their status before.

“Anything! No matter your condition, I will make sure that it will happen!” Gu Xiulan said.

“It’s quite simple, actually. If you want me to sell the Flood Dragon’s scale in your auction house, you’ll have to sell these treasures alongside it.”

Feng Yuxiang placed another spatial ring on the table.

“May I look at it?” Gu Xiulan asked.

“Go ahead.” Feng Yuxiang opened the spatial ring to let her peek inside.

Gu Xiulan’s jaw dropped when she saw the sheer amount of treasures in the spatial ring. Although they were not as valuable as the Flood Dragon’s scale

even when combined, it was the number that terrified her.

“This... Although I don’t mind selling them, it will take some time to sell all of them...”

“One week. I want you to sell all of them in one week. I don’t care how you do it. You can sell them across different auction houses, or you can open the auction house everyday. I will let you decide.” Feng Yuxiang said.

“Rest assured. I will make sure that all of the treasures in this spatial ring are turned to spirit stones within a week or less. I will put my name and reputation on the line.” Gu Xiulan said with a serious face.

“And in case you want to steal from my Young Master, just know that I have calculated approximately how much I can get for selling all of the treasures at its lowest price. I will also be watching the sales.”

“T-That will never happen! I am willing to put my life on the line! The House of Riches has existed for thousands of years, but we have never once stolen even a single copper coin from our dear customers! You can rest assured that you will receive every coin that it was sold for, not including the commission rates.”

“And speaking of commission rates, the House of Riches has a 10 percent commission fee, but I will make an exception for you by lowering it to 5 percent.”

However, Feng Yuxiang shook her head and said, “That won’t do.”

“Eh?”

Feng Yuxiang pointed at the Flood Dragon’s scale and said with a gentle smile on her face, “Make it one percent. Even with one percent, you’ll earn more than a month’s worth of fee just from the scale alone. If I give it to another auction house—one that is less prestigious, they might even sell it for free. It’s honor and reputation that’s the most important to an auction house that’s already as wealthy as the House of Riches, right?”

A bittersweet smile appeared on Gu Xiulan's face as she spoke, "I cannot argue with that. Very well, I shall lower the commission fee to 1 percent."

Even if Feng Yuxiang asked her to remove the commission fee completely, she would have still agreed. That's just how rare and precious the Flood Dragon's scale is. However, Feng Yuxiang had no reason to bully the House of Riches, so she spared them one percent of the sales.

As for the Flood Dragon's scale itself, of course, it wasn't part of what Yuan gave her to sell. It was something from her own collection that she'd acquired from the upper heavens, but in order to help Yuan sell his treasures as quickly and efficiently as possible, she decided to part ways with the treasure.

"Esteemed Guests, one last thing before we sell the treasures. Would you like to remain anonymous for the treasures? Most specifically, the Flood Dragon's scale." Gu Xiulan asked a moment later.

"Yes, sell them anonymously," she quickly responded.

"I understand."

Chapter 716 - Flood Dragon's Scale

Chapter 716: Flood Dragon's Scale

"I will go ahead and put all of these treasures on the priority sales list if you don't have anything else for me. If you wish to receive updates regarding the sales or have any other questions, you may visit our auction house at any time of the day and we'll assist you." Gu Xiulan said.

"I look forward to the results." Feng Yuxiang stood up and left the place shortly after, leaving behind her treasures for the auction house to sell.

"That woman... Do you think she's part of the Gu Family?" Xiao Hua asked after they left.

"Who knows. Gu is a very common surname, but the fact that she's working as the manager for a place like House of Riches suggests that she comes from a prestigious background." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Anyways, we have a week to spare. Do you have anything you want to do?"

Xiao Hua shook her head.

"Then I will go shopping. I need to restock medicine so the Young Master can continue to temper his body. You don't have to follow me if you don't want to. I will be fine by myself."

"Brother Yuan told me to protect you, so that is what I will do."

Feng Yuxiang shrugged nonchalantly, "As you wish."

After Feng Yuxiang and Xiao Hua left the auction house, Gu Xiulan immediately began preparing for the Flood Dragon's scale's auction, spreading its name far and wide until it reached even the most secluded areas in the Spirit Heaven, which was achieved in just three short days.

The news of House of Riches auctioning a Flood Dragon's scale spread like wildfire and caught the interest of almost all powerful families and backgrounds in the Spirit Heaven.

Not only has a Flood Dragon's scale never been sold in the Spirit Heaven before, but it was even a flawless scale.

However, if the Flood Dragon's scale was just rare, then it wouldn't create such hype.

A Flood Dragon's scale has many uses, and one of them is to increase the innate talent of cultivators that have water attribute spiritual veins. This effect alone is more than enough to make cultivators with water spirit veins go crazy, but they can also be used to craft high and peak quality Divine-grade treasures.

Any treasure that can increase a cultivator's talent, no matter how minimal its effect, would make any cultivators go crazy for it. After all, even if it increases someone's talent by one percent, some people only need just that much to break through their bottleneck and reach a new realm that wouldn't have been possible.

The largest families in the Spirit Heaven, the Seven Spirit Academies, and even hidden backgrounds began preparing for the auction that will definitely be unprecedented.

Meanwhile, somewhere in the Spirit Heaven, a group of high-ranking sect elders and the sect master gathered for a meeting.

The topic was, obviously, the Flood Dragon's scale.

"Should we participate in the auction and try to fight for the Flood Dragon's scale?" The Sect Master asked the elders.

“As much as I want our sect to obtain it... It’s going to be a bloody battle.”

“We can expect the other sects and even the Legacy Families to show up for this auction.”

“An auction of this scale... It’s going to be brutal for our finances. Hell, I’m not even sure that we’ll be able to win the auction.”

After listening to the elders’ feedback, the Sect Master nodded, “Alright, we’ll show up to the auction and set a maximum budget for the treasure. I also highly doubt we’ll be able to secure the Flood Dragon’s scale, but we have to try.”

Similar scenes happened throughout the Spirit Heaven within many families and sects.

While Gu Xiulan waited for the news to spread, she received a summoning call from her family.

“I assume the reason you called me back here is because of the Flood Dragon’s scale?” Gu Xiulan stood before the patriarch of the family.

“Yes, but that is not the only reason. We’ve just received a message from the Gu Family within the Lower Heavens. Those incompetent idiots had been robbed by someone that climbed the Stairway to Heaven shortly after, and they want us to kill the bandit and retrieve their treasures since these bandits are no longer in the Lower Heavens.”

Gu Xiulan raised her eyebrows.

“First of all... Why is it any of our business that they had been robbed? Should we also wipe their ass when they finish using the bathroom?” She asked.

The patriarch rubbed his temples in a stressed manner and sighed, “You see... This is not a simple robbery. They had been robbed of their family heirloom and amongst other valuable stuff.”

“What? Their heirloom had been robbed? Does that include the Gu Family’s legacy techniques?” Gu Xiulan was stunned to hear this.

“Unfortunately...”

“What a bunch of useless idiots! Even if they’re asking for our help, how can we possibly find the bandits in this vast world? It’ll be like looking for a needle in a haystack! If the Stairway to Heaven didn’t break, we could’ve found them easily because people rarely ascend nowadays. However, because the stairway is broken, we’ve had tens of thousands of newcomers in the last couple of days!”

The patriarch then said, “Since the bandits stole their treasure, there is a very good chance that they’ll be trying to sell the treasures. You work in the Houses of Riches, so you should have connections to many auction houses around Spirit Heaven. I will give you a list of the items that were stolen—at least the most notable ones. If they try to sell it at an auction, we will know.”

“Furthermore, we have their names and descriptions of their appearances. Min Li, Yuan, and Feng Yuxiang. As for their description...”

The patriarch began recalling all of the information given to him by the Gu Family in the Lower Heaven.

“Alright, I will spread this information to my associates.” Gu Xiulan nodded.

Chapter 717 - Helping Yuan

Chapter 717: Helping Yuan

‘A beautiful woman who wears seductive red robes and a little girl? They sound just like the esteemed guests with the Flood Dragon’s scale...’ Gu Xiulan thought about Feng Yuxiang and Xiao Hua after hearing their description.

However, she didn’t think for a second that it could actually be them. After all, how could someone that can sell a Flood Dragon’s scale be bandits? A single Flood Dragon’s scale is already worth more than what the entire Gu Family in the Lower Heavens own. There was simply no reason why they would rob the Gu Family.

Furthermore, neither Feng Yuxiang or Xiao Hua look like bandits. They were simply too high-class and noble to do something so lowly.

“Now let’s move onto the Flood Dragon’s scale. Do you know the identity of the seller? If our Gu Family can start a connection with them, that would be great.” The patriarch said.

Gu Xiulan shook her head, “Unfortunately, they didn’t provide me with their identity, and I didn’t dare to ask them since they seem to prefer staying anonymous.”

“That’s really unfortunate, indeed. Then can you tell me a little more about your encounter with them?”

Gu Xiulan nodded and proceeded to recall her conversation with them at the auction house.

“If this woman is really as you describe, her master must be an extraordinary individual.”

“The woman who did most of the talking should be a peak Spirit Grandmaster. The little girl beside her was at least Spirit Lord, but I am not certain since she hid her aura. It was a really weird encounter.” Gu Xiulan said.

“If you cannot see her aura, how are you so sure that she’s at least Spirit Lord?”

“You would understand it if you were there. I couldn’t sense her cultivation aura, but she had this cold aura around her that only killers would have. I was barely able to keep my focus with her staring at me the entire time.”

“She could be that woman’s bodyguard.”

“That’s what I thought too at first, but she just didn’t seem like a bodyguard. If you ask me, she felt more like a spectator... a bored one...”

“Forget it. The next time you meet, try to form a connection with them. If unsuccessful, just learn as much as you can about their identity. If they’re unwilling to become our allies, they could potentially become our enemies.”

Sometime later, Gu Xiulan said, “Is this all you have for me? I would like to return to the auction house since I still have a lot of treasures that I need to sell.”

“You may leave.”

Thus, Gu Xiulan left the place.

Although Gu Xiulan belongs to the Gu Family, she isn’t really a direct descendant of the Gu Family. In fact, while many people from the Gu Family may have their surname, it doesn’t mean that they share the same blood.

Therefore, she couldn't really care less about the Gu Family's problems, especially if they are not in the same realm. However, since she was asked by the patriarch, she has to try looking for the bandits at the very least.

Meanwhile, Feng Yuxiang went on a shopping spree in the Spirit Heaven, traveling from city to city with Xiao Hua to stock up on her treasures.

However, since she planned on using the treasures on Yuan, they can also be considered Yuan's treasures.

In fact, Feng Yuxiang had spent so much money that it made even Xiao Hua raise her eyebrows.

"Why are you buying so many treasures when Brother Yuan mentioned multiple times that he doesn't want to rely on you for everything? Once you sell all the treasures, he won't need to rely on you for a while." She eventually asked out of curiosity.

Feng Yuxiang smiled and said, "While that may be true, with his talents, he will eventually run out of money again. You know the saying 'the more talented, the more expenses'? With the Young Master's ridiculous talents, he will need an immense amount of wealth to properly train himself in the future, and that is where I come in."

"Although he doesn't like to rely on others for now, I believe that he will eventually rely more on us."

"What if Brother Yuan refuses to rely on us even in the future?" Xiao Hua then asked.

"Then I will help him from the shadows! If he doesn't know that we're helping him, it won't count as helping him!" Feng Yuxiang chuckled.

Xiao Hua was speechless.

"Brother Yuan will be angry if he finds out."

"What's the harm? It's not like I intend to spoon-feed him. I am just going to assist him ever so slightly whenever I can. For example, after we finish

selling the treasure, I am going to give the Young Master a little more than what the treasures sold for, and there will be no way for him to know about it unless one of us tells him.”

“...”

Xiao Hua looked at her with a dumbfounded face.

“Why are you looking at me like that? You also want to help him, don’t you? Unfortunately, the Young Master is still very naive, inexperienced, and very stubborn, so this is the only way we can help him.”

“If we don’t do this, we’ll never feel useful to him, and he will eventually reach that point where he’ll no longer need us. We need to take advantage of our current situation while we still can.”

Feng Yuxiang suddenly extended her hand that was holding a storage pouch, offering it to Xiao Hua.

“This is no different from that time when you went to the upper heavens to acquire Celestial Water for him. The only downside is that we won’t be praised for our efforts since he won’t know we helped him, but I will be satisfied just knowing that I had helped him.”

“What do you say, Xiao Hua? Let’s help the Young Master together.”

Seeing Feng Yuxiang’s serious face, Xiao Hua returned her gaze while pondering in silence.

After a moment of silence, Xiao Hua eventually accepted the storage pouch from Feng Yuxiang.

Feng Yuxiang immediately smiled, and she said, “Then it’s official! Let’s call this Operation Help the Young Master in Secret!”

“Don’t be mistaken, phoenix. I am only doing this for Brother Yuan.” Xiao Hua quickly said.

She added a second later, “And I prefer Operation Help Brother Yuan.”

“That’s the spirit!” Feng Yuxiang chuckled.

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Chapter 718 - Rematch

Chapter 718: Rematch

“What do you want me to do with this?” Xiao Hua lifted the storage pouch Feng Yuxiang gave her.

“Oh, there’s nothing but spirit stones inside. You can help me— the Young Master buy medicine for his body temperament.” Feng Yuxiang replied.

“You want me to go shopping with you...?” Xiao Hua mumbled.

Feng Yuxiang pondered for a moment before speaking, “How about this? Let’s have a rematch. I lost the previous one because you technically cheated by going to the upper heavens. This time, whoever purchases the most treasures will win.”

“That’s not fair.” Xiao Hua immediately frowned. “You have already spent 3 days buying many treasures.”

“Don’t worry, I won’t count those. I will also start from scratch, and I will limit my budget to your budget as well. How does that sound? That’s fair, right?”

“I guess...”

“But let me be really clear this time! You are not allowed to go to the upper heavens to purchase treasures! And the treasures purchased must be for body tempering!”

“I won’t.”

“Good! Then I will meet you at the House of Riches in four days, when the Flood Dragon’s scale is going to be auctioned off. May the best shopper win!”

After that, Feng Yuxiang and Xiao Hua went their separate ways, but they both had the same objective— to acquire as many treasures as possible.

Meanwhile, back at the hotel, Chu Liuxiang came out of her room after a week of studying her techniques.

“How’s your progress?” Yuan asked her.

“I managed to learn one of the techniques, but the other one might take a little bit longer. Despite both being Heaven-rank techniques, the Glacial Ice Dragon is much more complex. However, even if I learn both skills, I won’t be able to use either of them at my cultivation. I simply don’t have enough Qi.”

“I should really start cultivating properly. I am already behind as it is.” Chu Liuxiang sighed.

“Once Feng Feng finishes selling the treasures, I will be able to buy resources to boost your cultivation level.” Yuan said.

“As much as I like the feeling of being spoiled by you, I don’t like the feeling of taking advantage of you. Is there anything you want in return?”

“Not really. I don’t need any compensation for helping you, or it won’t feel like I am helping you.”

“It’s not a compensation. If you do me a favor, it’s only natural that I return the favor. It’s called expressing one’s gratitude, and that is being polite.”

“Even if I say that, there’s nothing that I want— at least I can’t think of anything right now.” Yuan shook his head.

“That’s okay. You can let me know once you think of something. Until then, I will be indebted to you.” Chu Liuxiang smiled.

“By the way, how’s your situation with your family? It’s almost the end of the month, you know?” Yuan suddenly asked.

A bittersweet smile appeared on her face as she spoke, “Their calls are becoming more frequent, and of course, my family is getting angrier.”

“It’s alright though. I will visit them at the end of this week to let them know my feelings,” she added.

“Okay.” Yuan nodded.

Sometime later, Yuan placed the level 3 array symbol manual down and asked Chu Liuxiang, “Do you want to get some food? I have watched thousands of people enter and leave this restaurant that’s directly across from us.”

“Sure. I need some fresh air, anyway.”

“What about you, Yingying?”

Lan Yingying transformed back to her human form and nodded, “Yes.”

“Let me ask Min as well.”

Yuan went to her room and knocked on her door.

“Min, we’re going to get some food. Would you like to come with us?”

Min Li’s voice responded a moment later, “Thank you for the invitation, but I am very close to a breakthrough.”

“Oh, sorry if I bothered you. And good luck with your breakthrough.”

Yuan left the hotel with Chu Liuxiang and Lan Yingying shortly after.

After walking a few steps, they arrived at the restaurant that was across from their hotel.

“Welcome to our humble restaurant. How many guests today?”

“Just the three of us.”

“Very well. Please, follow me to your table.”

Once they sat down, the waitress gave them a menu.

However, without even accepting the menu, Yuan said, “Just give us one of everything on the menu.”

“Eh? Are you sure?” The waitress looked at him with a baffled face.

“Yes.”

“I-I understand. Please wait a moment.”

The waitress went away and returned a couple of minutes later.

“This will be total. Are you okay with it?”

Yuan glanced at the bill and nodded, “Here, I will pay upfront. You can keep the change as well.”

“T-Thank you very much! The food will be here shortly!” The waitress quickly accepted Yuan’s gold coins without hesitation.

Once the waitress left, Chu Liuxiang smiled, “You sure are spending lavishly now that you’re rich.”

Yuan chuckled, “That’s not it. The higher my cultivation, the higher my appetite seems. If I don’t eat that much, I won’t feel satisfied.”

“Really? How come my appetite doesn’t increase?” Chu Liuxiang raised her eyebrows.

“Perhaps it has something to do with your physique.” Lan Yingying said.

“My physique also increases my appetite as my cultivation increases,” she added.

“That makes more sense. By the way, are you okay with not eating? I haven’t seen you consume magical beasts in a while.” Yuan asked.

She nodded, “Yes, I am fine. It’s not like I feel hunger if I don’t eat, and I don’t consume magical beasts to satisfy my hunger. It’s only to increase my cultivation. Also, I can not eat for months and remain perfectly fine. My increased appetite simply means that I can eat more if I decide to eat. Furthermore, I have already feasted enough when I traveled with Feng Yuxiang and Xiao Hua.”

“That’s good to hear. If you ever feel like eating, just let me know and I will go hunt some magical beasts with you.” Yuan said.

“Thank you.”

The food appeared shortly after, and they began eating.

While they ate, Yuan overheard the conversation of a few customers regarding an upcoming and unprecedented auction for a priceless treasure, which piqued his interest.

Chapter 719 - Powerhouses Gathering

Chapter 719: Powerhouses Gathering

“I heard the House of Riches in Bright Night City is preparing for their biggest auction since their creation!”

“Really? What are they selling this time?”

“It’s a treasure called Flood Dragon’s scale!”

“What the heck is that? But since it has the word dragon in its name, it must be very valuable...”

“According to the rumors, the Flood Dragon’s scale can increase a cultivator’s innate talent if they have water spirit veins.”

“What?! Increasing one’s innate talent?! That’s a priceless treasure!”

“Indeed. Pretty much every powerhouse is going to participate in the auction.”

“Good heavens. It’s going to be a bloodbath! I can’t even imagine how much money it will sell for.”

“It’s definitely going to be an amount that we can not even dream to have.”

After hearing this conversation, Yuan turned to look at Chu Liuxiang and said, “Lulu, this Flood Dragon’s scale is perfect for you. Even though you have ice spiritual veins, it should still work on you since your ice element is just a superior version of the water element.”

“You’re going to participate in this auction? It sounds very expensive...”
Chu Liuxiang said.

Yuan showed his spatial ring with a smile on his face, “I have plenty of money!”

Neither Yuan nor Chu Liuxiang was aware of the Flood Dragon’s scale’s true value. If they did, they wouldn’t even think about trying to participate in the auction.

“I have almost 20,000 spirit stones. That’s worth 200 million gold coins. Surely, that’s more than enough to buy this treasure, right? Even a Heaven-grade treasure is only worth at most 50 million.” Yuan said.

“We’ll find out when we get there, I guess.” Chu Liuxiang shrugged.

“What about the others?” Lan Yingying said. “You told them that you wouldn’t leave the hotel...”

“Well... We don’t know when they’ll return, and we might miss the auction if we wait for them. I will leave a note behind if they return while we are away so that they don’t panic about our disappearance.”

Chu Liuxiang then said, “There’s actually a good chance that we’ll run into them since they will also be selling their treasures in an auction house.”

“Now that you mention it, that could also happen.” Yuan said.

Once they finished eating, they returned to the hotel.

Yuan immediately began writing his note for the others.

“Since Min is busy with her cultivation, I won’t bother her. Are you guys ready to leave?” Yuan asked them afterward.

“Do you even know where to go?” Chu Liuxiang then asked.

“Oh, I nearly forgot. It’s a city called Bright Night City. Can either of you read maps?” Yuan handed them the jade slip containing a map.

“I can try.” Lan Yingying said as she took the jade slip.

A few moments later, she spoke, “It’s a little far from this place, but we should arrive there by the end of the day if we use teleportation devices.”

“Alright, you’ll lead the way.” Yuan said.

Before they left, Yuan placed the note on the table and used a cup to hold it down to ensure that it wouldn’t move anywhere.

Thus, Yuan began making his way towards Bright Night City with Lan Yingying and Chu Liuxiang.

Meanwhile, somewhere in the Spirit Healing Academy, Wang Xiuying went to look for her Master after being summoned.

“Disciple Wang greets Master.” Wang Xiuying bowed to her Master at the sect, who was a beautiful middle-aged woman with a naturally cold face.

“Xiuying, I will be leaving the sect for a couple of days to participate in the Flood Dragon’s scale’s auction with the sect master.”

“Oh, I heard about that! It’s a priceless treasure that can improve one’s innate talent, is that correct?”

“Yes, but it has many other purposes as well, such as being used to create the Flood Dragon Pill that can directly boost a peak Spirit Lord to a Spirit King with 90 percent efficiency! However, since it’s a flawless scale, it should have more than 95 percent efficiency!”

“I-Is that so...” Wang Xiuying mumbled in a dazed voice. She has never seen her Master so excited before.

“Want to come with us? It will be a unique experience for you since all of the powerhouses will be present for the auction, and they are some of the most powerful people in this world.”

“I want to go!” Wang Xiuying immediately nodded her head.

“Alright. Get ready. We’re leaving in an hour.”

Ten hours later, Yuan arrived at the Bright Night City.

“Wow, there’s a lot of people here...” Yuan cannot recall the last time he saw this many people gathered in one place.

However, the most impressive part was that they were mostly flying in the air and the profound atmosphere there.

“Most of them are emitting a powerful aura as well... They must all be cultivation experts.” Chu Liuxiang couldn’t stop shivering, as the atmosphere caused by these experts was too intense for a Spirit Apprentice like her.

“Are you okay?” Yuan asked her.

“Yes... It just feels a little harder to breathe than usual...”

Hearing her words, Yuan used his spiritual energy to cover her body.

Chu Liuxiang immediately felt better.

“Do you feel any better?” Yuan asked.

“Yes, I feel much better. Thank you.”

“What about you, Yingying?”

“I am fine. The pressure doesn’t affect me.”

“That’s good to hear.” Yuan said, and he continued, “Now that we’re here, let’s figure out where and when the auction will take place.”

“Okay.” The ladies nodded.

After entering the city, they began asking around.

“Hello, do you know where the Flood Dragon’s scale’s auction will take place? Or where I can find more information on it?” Yuan asked a couple of pedestrians the same question.

One of them replied, “You can learn more about the auction at the House of Riches. Besides that, I don’t really know anything, since this auction is not going to be public.”

“What do you mean it’s not going to be public?” Yuan raised his eyebrows.

“It means that only those invited and influential enough are allowed to participate in the auction. After all, an auction of this significance will attract too many people, so they are only limiting it to people that are actually wealthy enough to participate.”

“I see... That makes sense. Thank you.”

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Chapter 720 - Invitation to the Auction

Chapter 720: Invitation to the Auction

Now that he knew where to go, Yuan and the others made their way to the House of Riches.

However, there were so many pedestrians out in the street that it made walking extremely difficult and bothersome.

“Why are there so many people? Since the auction is exclusive, they have no business crowding up the streets!” Chu Liuxiang sighed.

“They probably want to meet some of the powerhouses that came here for the auction. It’s really rare for them to appear in public like this, much less this many at once, so they want to use this chance to change their fate. They might never get another chance, after all.” Lan Yingying said.

“That makes a lot of sense.” Chu Liuxiang mumbled.

“Let’s fly since we won’t be able to go anywhere like it.” Yuan suggested.

A few moments later, Yuan carried Chu Liuxiang into the air while Lan Yingying followed him.

“Wow! What young experts!”

The pedestrians were awed when they saw Yuan and Lan Yingying flying without any flying treasures, meaning they were Spirit Grandmasters and above.

Sometime later, Yuan arrived at the House of Riches, which was incredibly easy to spot due to how many experts were gathered there.

“Hmm? Who is that? Do you recognize him, Sect Master Jing?”

“No, I don’t.”

The experts there began mumbling to each other when Yuan and Lan Yingying showed up, as they had never seen either of them before.

“Excuse me, is this where we get our invitation to the auction?” Yuan asked one of the experts there.

“Hm? Yeah. Someone from the auction house should be giving us more information in a bit.”

“Thank you.”

“By the way, who are you with? I know most Spirit Lords, but I don’t recognize you.” The man then asked him.

“I’m a rogue cultivator.” Yuan said with a smile.

“A rogue cultivator...?” The man raised his eyebrows.

How can a Spirit Lord at his age possibly be a rogue cultivator? Even a blind man could tell that he was lying. However, the man didn’t continue to question him and accepted it as it is. After all, if a cultivator wants to remain anonymous, their wish should be respected.

A few minutes later, someone from the House of Riches appeared before them and said out loud, “Thank you all for showing interest in our upcoming auction for the Flood Dragon’s scale. However, in order to not overwhelm the auction, we have decided to limit the number of participants. In order to receive an invite, you must show us proof of your identity and that you belong to a prominent background. If you wish to remain anonymous, you must prove to us that you have the qualifications to participate in the auction. Therefore, we will ask that you show us at least 500,000 spirit stones or treasures of that value.”

‘F-Five hundred thousand spirit stones?!?!?’ Yuan cried inwardly when he heard this astronomical number.

“Yuan...” Chu Liuxiang looked at him with a worried face. “How much did you say you brought again? 20,000...?”

A bittersweet smile appeared on Yuan’s face when he realized that he’d severely underestimated the Flood Dragon’s scale’s worth.

Unless he sold all of the Gu Family’s treasures, he wouldn’t even be able to participate in the auction. Of course, he could just show them the Gu Family’s treasures that should be worth a few billion gold, but it was incredibly risky because of the destiny seals in the treasures.

However, since he was already here, he didn’t want to go back empty handed.

Yuan decided that he will at the very least witness this auction even if he doesn’t manage to win the Flood Dragon’s scale.

Thus, Yuan began pondering about what he had on him that was worth 500,000 spirit stones, excluding the Gu Family’s treasures.

‘Actually... Now that I think about it, I should have a few valuable treasures. Although I don’t know their full value, let’s hope they are worth more than 500,000 spirit stones... If not, I still have one last trick up my sleeve...’

Yuan looked at Chu Liuxiang and said, “Don’t worry, we should be able to participate.”

While the House of Riches verified the experts there one by one, Yuan waited anxiously for his turn.

Half an hour later, it was finally their turn.

“Hello. Would you like to show us your identity or your qualifications?” The pretty woman asked Yuan with a calm smile.

“I’d like to show my qualifications.” Yuan said as he retrieved a colorful plant from his spatial ring.

“T-This is...” The woman’s eyes widened with surprise when she saw the plant in Yuan’s hands.

“Correct me if I am wrong, but is this the Seven Colored Herb?” She asked him for confirmation in a shaky voice.

“Yes, it is. Can I get an invitation with this, or do I need to show more?” Yuan asked, silently hoping that it was enough.

“O-Of course!”

To their surprise, the woman quickly approved.

“Really?”

It was so easy that Yuan was in disbelief.

“Yes. Here’s your invitation letter. The auction will begin in two days. The location and time of the auction is already written inside the letter. Good luck at the auction, esteemed guest.” The woman bowed to him in a respectful manner.

Yuan accepted the letter and quickly stored it back into his spatial ring alongside the Seven Colored Herb.

They left the scene shortly after to find a hotel, where they can stay for the next two days.

“Wow, you surprised me back there, Yuan. What did you show her?” Chu Liuxiang asked him out of curiosity after they sat down in the hotel.

“This.” Yuan showed her the Seven Colored Herb.

“This little plant is worth more than 500,00 spirit stones? That’s 5 billion gold coins! I don’t believe it!” She expressed her disbelief.

“I don’t know what to tell you since I also didn’t expect it to be worth so much money. However, Xiao Hua was very excited when we first acquired it, and she doesn’t get excited easily.” Yuan shrugged.

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Chapter 721 - Royal Hall

Chapter 721: Royal Hall

“How did you acquire it?” Chu Liuxiang asked out of curiosity.

“Well, it started when we met this man in front of a cave...” Yuan proceeded to recall his experience with the Demonic Spider.

“That’s... very tragic...” Chu Liuxiang sighed in a dispirited voice after hearing the story.

“Hearing your story makes me wonder... Does it hurt more for the parents to lose their children, or does it hurt more for the children when they lose their parents?”

“I don’t think we can gauge pain...” Yuan shook his head.

“Yuan, have you ever thought about meeting your parents? Your biological parents, I mean.”

“Not really. I never had the time to worry about such things, either. They abandoned me for a reason, and there’s no point thinking about it since it’s already happened.”

“You’re not even slightest curious why they abandoned you? I sometimes wonder why they really abandoned me.” Chu Liuxiang sighed again, and she continued, “Unfortunately, we might never be able to find the answer even if we wanted to ask them. For all we know, they could be dead right now. Even if they’re not, it’s almost impossible to look for them.”

Yuan smiled bitterly and said, “Let’s stop thinking about such depressing things. Your hair will turn white from stress.”

“Alright, I am going to study my techniques. Call me when it’s time to go.” Chu Liuxiang said as she retrieved her techniques and began reading them.

“I also need to finish absorbing the magical beasts I consumed before.” Lan Yingying said as she turned into a bracelet around his wrist.

Yuan didn’t say anything else and returned to studying his arrays.

Two days passed in the blink of an eye.

“Lulu, it’s almost time for the auction.” Yuan called out to her.

“Let’s go!”

Thus, they began making their way towards the auction, which will be held in another location that will have a higher capacity for the guests.

Meanwhile, Feng Yuxiang and Xiao Hua met up with each other in front of the House of Riches around the same time.

“How did your shopping go?” Feng Yuxiang asked her with a confident face.

“...”

Xiao Hua didn’t say anything and handed the spatial ring with the treasures she bought inside to Feng Yuxiang.

Feng Yuxiang quickly checked the contents, and it was lacking in terms of quantity. However, in terms of quality, the treasures Xiao Hua bought were much better in general.

“I see... So you picked quality over quantity, huh? Unfortunately, I have won this rematch!” Feng Yuxiang said in a proud voice as she handed her spatial ring to Xiao Hua.

Xiao Hua frowned slightly and looked at the spatial ring, and to her surprise, Feng Yuxiang had a lot more treasures than her while keeping its quality about the same.

“You must be thinking that I had cheated, right? After all, how can I possibly acquire so much more treasures with the same quality while having the same budget?”

Although Xiao Hua didn’t say anything, she indeed doubted if Feng Yuxiang had cheated for a moment.

“Xiao Hua, it’s simply a difference in experience. You most likely bought those treasures at their full price, right? Well, I convinced the merchants to sell the treasures at a lower price, allowing me to buy more with the same budget. Furthermore, I didn’t buy them in regular stores, since you can usually get treasures of the same quality with a merchant that works alone, and they’re easier to haggle with.” Feng Yuxiang explained, displaying her years of experience as a merchant in full, even bragging about it a little.

“...”

After hearing Feng Yuxiang’s explanation, Xiao Hua had no choice but to accept her defeat this time. She wasn’t the type to haggle with others, nor has she done so before, so she was at a severe disadvantage for this match.

“Now that we both have a win and loss, we’re tied. I look forward to our next match” Feng Yuxiang then said.

“I won’t lose next time.” Xiao Hua said in a calm voice, yet her fierce expression was dead serious.

“Neither will I.” Feng Yuxiang said with a smile.

Thus, the rivalry between Feng Yuxiang and Xiao Hua to become Yuan’s number one servant officially began.

“Esteemed guests! You came just at the right time! I was just about to head to the auction. Do you want to join me?” Gu Xiulan was pleasantly surprised to see them standing in front of the auction house.

“Sure.” Feng Yuxiang nodded.

While they journeyed, Gu Xiulan said to them, “Regarding the sales of the treasures, we have managed to sell all of them besides the Flood Dragon’s scale, which will be sold by today. In total, the treasures managed to sell for a little over 60,000 spirit stones.”

“Good.” Feng Yuxiang replied in a nonchalant manner.

Although Gu Xiulan didn’t mention it, nor would she, most of the treasures were actually bought by the auction house itself.

After all, with the Flood Dragon’s scale’s upcoming auction, most of the wealthy families have decided to save as much money as they can for the auction, making it pretty hard to sell the lesser valued treasures even for a renowned auction house like the House of Riches.

In fact, the House of Riches even bought most of the treasures at a higher price than usual just to satisfy Feng Yuxiang.

And although the House of Riches will be losing some money even if they manage to sell all of the treasures in the future when everything has calmed down, they do not regret their actions as long as it satisfies Feng Yuxiang.

About an hour later, they arrive at the location of the auction. It was in a nearby city, where there was a massive building that could hold thousands of guests with ease.

This building was built for important meetings for the Seven Legacy Families, the Seven Spirit Academies, among other powerful backgrounds, but it will be used as an auction house just for the Flood Dragon’s scale.

“Welcome to the Royal Hall, Esteemed Guests.” Gu Xiulan said to them when they arrived.

Chapter 722 - Flood Dragon's Scale Auction

Chapter 722: Flood Dragon's Scale Auction

“Here are the VIP seats, Esteemed Guests. I have to prepare for the auction, so I will excuse myself now.” Gu Xiulan said to Feng Yuxiang after showing her the best seats in the house.

Feng Yuxiang and Xiao Hua took a seat shortly after, and their presence immediately attracted the gazes of the people that were already there, all of whom were considered VIP, such as the Seven Legacy Families and the Seven Spirit Academies.

“Excuse me, beautiful fairy. I know this is audacious of me, but I do not recognize you. Please spare me of this guilt by telling me your name.” A handsome man sitting two seats away from them suddenly asked Feng Yuxiang with this charming smile.

But before Feng Yuxiang could respond, he continued to speak, “Oh, how disrespectful of me. I am the sect master of the Universal Music Academy, Sun Hao.”

“...”

Unfortunately, Feng Yuxiang didn't even bother to spare him a single word, much less her name.

Some of the people there began laughing in a suppressed manner when they saw Sun Hao's flushed face and embarrassed expression.

To dare disrespect one of Seven Spirit Academies' Sect Masters in such a manner, the people there became even more interested in Feng Yuxiang's identity.

'Huh? Aren't those two...?' Wang Xiuying recognized Feng Yuxiang and Xiao Hua.

She remembered seeing them with Yuan at the Mystic Realm. And while it was only for a brief moment, their attractive appearances made it easy for her to remember.

'What are they doing here? Wait... Does this mean Yuan is also here? He ascended to Spirit Heaven recently, too.' Wang Xiuying immediately became excited at the possibility that Yuan was nearby, as it has been a long time since they have seen each other.

She began looking around for Yuan, but sadly, the VIP section was separated from the others, making it very difficult to look for him.

As for Yuan, he sat down with Lan Yingying and Chu Liuxiang the moment they found three available seats so they could sit together, and their seats were all the way at the end of the conference room, where the auction is being held.

"Wow, this feels like we're at an important meeting." Chu Liuxiang mumbled in a low voice.

"The atmosphere and the building's interior does give off that feeling." Yuan agreed with her.

Half an hour later, Gu Xiulan appeared before everyone in the center of the building, where a large circular platform existed.

"Welcome, everyone! Thank you all for coming to our auction today on such short notice! My name is Gu Xiulan, and I have been a manager at the House of Riches for over 5 decades. It is with great honor that I bring to you today a priceless treasure that can only be found in the Fourth Heaven and above—the scale of a Flood Dragon!"

The audience immediately became dead silent when Gu Xiulan started talking.

‘Gu Xiulan...? Is she part of the Gu Family or am I just being paranoid? Gu is a common surname, after all...’ Yuan thought to himself when he heard her name.

“Before I continue, allow me to show you all the Flood Dragon’s scale.”

Everyone there focused their gazes on Gu Xiulan and watched as she retrieved a beautiful box before placing it on the display stand beside her.

“Make sure you engrave this moment into your soul because there’s a good chance that you will never see something like this ever again after today!”

Gu Xiulan opened up the box, revealing the glistening blue scale inside the box that was also emitting an overwhelming aura.

Many gasps of awe could be heard from the audience as they witnessed the Flood Dragon’s scale for the first time in their lives.

“As you can all see, this is the Flood Dragon’s scale— one of flawless quality, as well. There are many benefits this scale can bring to you. Here’s just a few of many benefits. It can increase the innate talent of a cultivator with water spiritual veins. It can be used to concoct the Flood Dragon Pill that can help a peak Spirit Lord achieve Spirit King with great success. It can also be used to craft high-quality Divine-grade treasures.”

The cultivators there salivated with desire as Gu Xiulan introduced the Flood Dragon’s scale.

“I will now give everyone three minutes to prepare before I officially begin the auction.” Gu Xiulan said.

Immediately, the entire place erupted with murmurs, but with so many people speaking at once, it sounded quite loud even if they were all whispering to each other.

“This Flood Dragon’s scale is exactly what I need to breakthrough to Spirit King! We must get it at all costs!” Said a certain cultivator that had been stuck as a Spirit Lord for over three decades.

“I have water spiritual veins! This Flood Dragon’s scale will boost my talents to a new level! We cannot miss this chance!” Said a certain Sect Master of a prominent sect.

“With this Flood Dragon’s scale, I will finally be able to concoct the pill of my dream— a tier 6 pill!”

“This is going to be one brutal auction...” Chu Liuxiang sighed at the atmosphere that suddenly became tense.

“I don’t blame them for wanting such a priceless treasure. If I had the funds, I would also want to bid for it.” Yuan said.

Three minutes passed in the blink of an eye.

Gu Xiulan cleared her throat before speaking.

“I hope you’re all prepared, because the auction for the Flood Dragon’s scale starts now! To start off the bid, 100,000 spirit stones with increments of at least 10,000 spirit stones!”

“She started the auction at a billion gold?! I definitely underestimate this auction! Severely, at that!” Yuan cried inwardly, and he realized that he never had a place in this auction since the very beginning.

As for the others, they did not hesitate to bid.

“110,000 spirit stones!”

“150,000 spirit stones!”

“200,000 spirit stones!”

In just a few minutes, the highest bid reached 400,000 spirit stones, which was a record in the history of all auction houses in the Spirit Heaven,

shattering the previous record by over 100,000 spirit stones!

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Chapter 723 - Winner of the Auction

Chapter 723: Winner of the Auction

“400,000 spirit stones!”

“410,000 spirit stones!”

“420,000 spirit stones!”

Even though the auction is already at 400,000 spirit stones, which is worth 4 billion gold, the atmosphere there did not quiet down and remained as tense as ever. In fact, it was only getting more tense.

“450,000 spirit stones!”

“470,000 spirit stones!”

“500,000 spirit stones!”

When the spirit stones reached 500,000 spirit stones, someone there suddenly increased the bid significantly.

“One million spirit stones!”

Many bidders there turned to look at the person who just spoke with raised eyebrows.

While nobody there doubted for a second that the bid wouldn't reach that price point, they didn't want such an exciting auction to end so early. After all, they could simply bid their maximum budget at one go and call it a day.

However, that would be boring, and such actions are frowned upon in auctions, sort of like an unspoken rule.

“Slow down, Bai Ning. I know you want the Flood Dragon’s scale very badly, but let’s enjoy ourselves in this unprecedented event that might never happen again. Furthermore, you wouldn’t want the auction to end in an instant, do you? This might be your last chance looking at the Flood Dragon’s scale so closely, after all.” Someone there called out the individual, publicly shaming him.

“If you don’t shut up, I will increase it by another million,” said the man in a sneering manner.

“1,010,000 spirit stones!”

The people there continued to bid shortly after.

Inside the VIP room, Xiao Hua suddenly raised her eyebrows.

She turned to look at Feng Yuxiang and said, “Phoenix, I can sense Brother Yuan’s presence in this place...”

Feng Yuxiang immediately snapped her head at her and exclaimed in a low voice, “What?! Impossible! What’s he doing here?!”

She quickly tried to sense Yuan’s presence through their servant and master connection, and sure enough, she was able to sense his presence as well, albeit a little faint.

“W-What is the Young Master doing here?! If he finds out that we’re selling the Flood Dragon’s scale to help him, he might be a little upset...”

“I don’t think Brother Yuan will be upset.” Xiao Hua said.

“But just to be safe, we should keep this a secret from him until we know how he feels about the auction.” Feng Yuxiang sighed.

The auction continued for another thirty minutes, reaching two million spirit stones.

“Heavens, it’s already 20 billion gold... Just how much wealth do these cultivators have?” Yuan mumbled in a dazed voice.

He thought having a couple billion of gold was already wealthy, but compared to these powerhouses, it was like a drop of water in the ocean.

“If you think about it, they had thousands of years to save up this much money.” Chu Liuxiang said.

“Gold coins are still considered mortal currency, so it’s not abnormal that they have so many. Spirit stones are the true currency for cultivators. One million spirit stones may be an astronomical amount for mortals since they automatically convert it to gold, but for cultivators, a million spirit stones is just one million spirit stones. And with cultivators monopolizing spirit stone caves, it should be easier for them to acquire spirit stones.” Lan Yingying said.

“Oh, right. Spirit Stone Caves. I nearly forgot about their existence, but that makes a lot more sense.” Yuan said.

“Three million spirit stones!”

The Flood Dragon’s scale reached a new milestone very quickly.

After another hour, the highest bid reached 5 million spirit stones.

“Five million spirit stones! The Healing Spirit Academy has bid 5 million spirit stones! Do we have any more bids?!” Gu Xiulan announced.

“5,500,000 spirit stones!” The Sect Master of the Lonely River Academy raised the bid from the VIP section.

“6,000,000!” The patriarch of the Gu Family shouted.

“7 million!” A man that most did not recognize increased the bid by another million.

By now the bids were increasing by large increments of over 500,000 spirit stones. In other words, it was time for the real auction to begin.

And in just a couple of minutes, the highest bid went from 7 million all the way to 12 million spirit stones!

“Whoever this Flood Dragon’s scale belongs to... They are going to be rich after this auction...” Yuan mumbled as he watched the bid increase by another 3 million, reaching 15 million spirit stones within a matter of moments.

“15 million! Does anyone have better than 15 million?!” Gu Xiulan exclaimed with excitement.

“20 million!” A familiar voice suddenly resounded in the building.

‘This voice... Senior Nie?’ Yuan recognized this voice as Senior Nie, the Spirit King who descended to the Lower Heavens to oversee the Mystic Realm.

“Oh! Senior Nie of the Heavenly Academy has bid 20 million spirit stones!”

The auction came to a halt for the first time after reaching 20 million.

20 million spirit stones could support an entire sect the size of the Seven Spirit Academies for many years, and to use it to buy a single treasure, it made even the richest people there hesitant.

Furthermore, the Heavenly Academy is the strongest and most influential out of the Seven Spirit Academies. It would be unwise to fight them even though it was an auction.

“20 million spirit stones going once!”

“Going twice!”

“And sold! Congratulations to Senior Nie of the Heavenly Academy for acquiring the Flood Dragon’s scale for 20 million spirit stones!” Gu Xiulan announced the winner of the auction.

“So it’s finally done, huh. It’s unfortunate that we couldn’t get the Flood Dragon’s scale now, but once we reach the fourth heaven, I will hunt some Flood Dragon for you. Surely, they must drop more than one scale, right?” Yuan said to Chu Liuxiang.

“It’s fine, Yuan. It’s your thoughts that really count.” Chu Liuxiang showed a heartwarming smile.

“Now that the auction is over, let’s return to the hotel,” she continued.

“Yes... Hm? Wait a second. I can sense Feng Feng and Xiao Hua’s presence nearby. I think they’re closeby.” Yuan suddenly said.

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Chapter 724 - Their Young Master

Chapter 724: Their Young Master

“Really? Then do you know where they are?” Chu Liuxiang asked.

“Not exactly. I know they’re nearby, but I don’t know where they are. Hold on, let me ask them.”

“Feng Feng? Xiao Hua? Are you two also at the Flood Dragon’s scale auction?” Yuan asked them through their connection.

“Y-Young Master? Are you also at the auction?” Feng Yuxiang’s surprised voice resounded, almost as though she wasn’t aware until he spoke to her.

“Yes, I decided to participate in the auction when I heard about it, but alas, I had no chance against these powerful families and sects. And before you tell me that I wasn’t supposed to leave the hotel, I left a note behind before we left.” Yuan said.

“Don’t worry, I am not mad at you for leaving.” Feng Yuxiang chuckled.

“Anyways, now that the auction has ended, let’s meet up.”

“W-Wait a minute, Young Master. I still have a few treasures to sell, so we cannot meet up just yet. If you want, you can return to the hotel first...”
Feng Yuxiang quickly made up an excuse so that she wouldn’t expose herself for selling the Flood Dragon’s scale.

“Is that so? Do you know how long it will take? If it’s not too long, we can wait for you in our hotel at Bright Night City.” Yuan then said.

“It shouldn’t take too long. We should be finished by the end of today or tomorrow.”

“I understand. Then we’ll wait for you at Bright Night City.” Yuan proceeded to give her the name of their hotel.

“They’re almost finished selling the treasures, so we’re going to wait for them in our hotel at Bright Night City.” Yuan explained the situation to Chu Liuxiang and Lan Yingying.

“Thank you all for coming to our action today! If you have any questions, you may visit the House of Riches located in Bright Night City at any time!” Gu Xiulan said to everyone there before leaving the stage.

Many people at the auction wanted to ask about the owner of the Flood Dragon’s scale, but they figured that if this person wanted their identity to be known, Gu Xiulan would’ve already mentioned it.

The fact that they were not mentioned must either mean Gu Xiulan doesn’t know, or the seller doesn’t want their identity to be known. It was that simple.

After leaving the Royal Hall, Yuan’s group returned to Bright Night City while Feng Yuxiang and Xiao Hua waited to collect their money.

As for Senior Nie, he went to a private room with Gu Xiulan, where he paid her the 20 million spirit stones for the Flood Dragon’s scale.

“I know you probably don’t want to tell me their identity, but I still wish to ask.” Senior Nie asked Gu Xiulan as he handed her the spirit stones.

Gu Xiulan shook her head with a bittersweet smile, “It’s not that I don’t want to tell you. I simply don’t know their identity.”

“That’s unfortunate.” Senior Nie said.

However, just as Gu Xiulan handed Senior Nie the Flood Dragon’s scale, the door to the VIP room opened, and Feng Yuxiang and Xiao Hua casually walked inside the room.

“Y-You are...” Senior Nie’s eyes widened with surprise when he saw Xiao Hua and recognized her.

“Hey, do you have the money yet? I don’t like the feeling of making the Young Master wait. And the more I think about it, the more anxious I get.” Feng Yuxiang ignored Senior Nie and directly asked for the money.

Gu Xiulan was speechless. She thought they wanted to remain anonymous, so what are they doing here?

“You were in the Lower Heavens at the Mystic Realm! What are you doing here?” Senior Nie eventually snapped out of his shock and asked Xiao Hua.

“That’s none of your business.” Xiao Hua nonchalantly responded.

“Uhh... Here’s the spirit stones for the other treasures you asked us to sell. The commission fee has already been deducted. As for the 20 million spirit stones, give me a moment to separate them.”

Gu Xiulan quickly subtracted 200,000 spirit stones from the 20 million as part of their 1 percent commission fee. After that, she handed the rest to Feng Yuxiang.

“19,861,000 spirit stones, huh? Not bad.” Feng Yuxiang said after a quick count using her divine sense.

She then retrieved another spatial ring that was empty before putting in 120,000 spirit stones from the 19 million.

Yuan’s treasure had sold for a little over 60,000 spirit stones, but Feng Yuxiang decided to add a tiny percentage of her own earnings into it to help him.

Of course, this ‘tiny amount’ was already enough to double his earnings, but Yuan won’t know that unless she tells him.

“Thanks for the work.” Feng Yuxiang said to Gu Xiulan as she turned around and began walking for the exit.

“P-Please wait a moment!” Gu Xiulan suddenly stopped them.

However, she didn’t know exactly why she stopped them, and she did it mostly subconsciously.

“Is there something else?” Feng Yuxiang asked her.

“Uhhh... N-No. Sorry.” Gu Xiulan gave up trying to learn more about them.

In fact, Senior Nie appears to recognize one of them, so she could simply ask him later.

Feng Yuxiang and Xiao Hua left the scene shortly after.

“They’re the owners of the Flood Dragon’s scale...? Unbelievable...” Senior Nie mumbled in a dazed voice after they left.

“You know them?” Gu Xiulan asked him.

“Well... I wouldn’t say that I ‘know’ them, but I have met them before... In the Lower Heavens.” He said.

“What?! The Lower Heavens?!”

Senior Nie nodded, and he proceeded to recall their brief encounter at the Mystic Realm to Gu Xiulan.

“That little girl was a Spirit King?!” Gu Xiulan’s jaw dropped after learning this information.

After a moment of silence, she asked, “Wait. Did you also see their ‘Young Master’ by any chance?”

“Young Master? Oh, you must mean that genius who conquered the Mystic Realm. If I recall correctly, his name was ‘Yuan’.”

Gu Xiulan’s eyes widened with shock when she heard this familiar name.

“Wait a second... Did you just say... Yuan?” She asked for confirmation.

“Yes. Do you know him?” Senior Nie nodded.

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Chapter 725 - Mysterious Box

Chapter 725: Mysterious Box

“I... No, I don’t know him. I only heard about his name from someone else, that’s all.” Gu Xiulan denied knowing about Yuan after snapping out of her daze.

“Anyways, here’s your Flood Dragon’s scale. Please enjoy. I have another business to attend to, so if you’ll excuse me. Ah, if you have any questions, you can always come back here to find me.”

After taking one last look at the Flood Dragon’s scale, Gu Xiulan handed it to Senior Nie.

“Thank you.” Senior Nie accepted the treasure with trembling hands, feeling like a child on his birthday.

Once Senior Nie left the place, Gu Xiulan took a seat on the couch and began pondering profusely.

“A beautiful woman who likes to wear revealing red clothes... A little girl with a profound aura... The mastermind, Yuan... And last but not least, they were in the Lower Heavens not long ago... There is too much evidence for it to be just a coincidence.”

“But I don’t get it. Why would she rob the Gu Family? Clearly, they have a lot of money, so they didn’t steal because they needed the money. Perhaps they have a grudge with the Gu Family? Did those idiots offend them somehow?”

Gu Xiulan had no doubt that the Gu Family in the Lower Heavens were capable of offending someone like Feng Yuxiang and her group.

“What should I do now that I have this information? Should I just tell the patriarch? He might forgive them if I tell him about the Flood Dragon’s scale, but I also don’t have any evidence.”

“However, if I tell him and he still wants to hunt them, that would also be problematic. The fact that they were just in the Lower Heaven alongside the Flood Dragon’s scale, there’s a good chance that they are actually from the upper heavens. As for why they decided to come down... heaven knows. “

Gu Xiulan proceeded to spend the rest of the day pondering.

Eventually, she had enough.

“Ahhhh! Why the hell am I stressing myself over those idiot’s’ situation?” She scratched her head furiously.

“Whether they are at fault or not, I don’t care! They clearly dug themselves this hole, so why should I help them refill the hole?! Screw it! I don’t care anymore! I will just act like I never heard anything today!”

“I just held an unprecedented auction! I should be celebrating right now!”

Thus, Gu Xiulan decided to take herself out of their problem and act like she wasn’t involved.

Meanwhile, at Bright Night City, Feng Yuxiang and Xiao Hua arrived at the location of Yuan’s hotel.

“Alright, Xiao Hua. Just as we planned.” Feng Yuxiang took a deep breath and knocked on the door.

“Young Master. We’re back.”

Yuan opened the door a few moments later with a surprised look on his face.

“You’re back already?”

“Yes, we managed to sell the treasures quicker than expected. Here’s all of the money from the sale.” Feng Yuxiang handed him the spatial ring with 120,000 spirit stones.

Yuan accepted the spatial ring and immediately looked inside.

“120,000 spirit stones? That’s pretty good.” He said in a calm voice.

“Are you not satisfied with the result, Young Master?” Feng Yuxiang was greatly surprised by his nonchalant reaction.

They even doubled the actual earnings to please him! Would he have reacted angrily if they didn’t and the earning was much less?

“Huh? It’s not that I’m not satisfied. But after participating... No, witnessing the auction for the Flood Dragon’s scale, my perspective has changed a little. I have realized just how little this amount of money really is, and I am having a hard time getting excited about it.” He sighed, explaining to them his lackluster reaction.

“I see... So that’s the reason...” Feng Yuxiang sighed in relief inwardly after learning the truth.

“Oh, but don’t misunderstand. Even though my perspective has changed a little, I am still very grateful to you for helping me sell it! Thank you, Feng Feng. And thank you, Xiao Hua, for keeping her safe.” Yuan said with a bright smile on his face.

When Feng Yuxiang saw his smile, she felt something flare up within her phoenix heart.

“Y-Young Master! You went to the auction because you were interested in the Flood Dragon’s scale, right?” She suddenly asked him.

“Yes. I wanted to get it for Lulu, who has ice element spiritual veins. It should work on her since it’s technically still water element, right?”

“Yes, it would work on her since ice element is just an upgraded version of water element.” Feng Yuxiang nodded.

She then reached into her spatial ring and retrieved a wooden box.

“Here, Young Master. It’s for you.”

“What’s this?” Yuan raised his eyebrows at this mysterious box.

“Just a little gift from me.” She chuckled.

“Go ahead. Open it.”

Yuan nodded, but he didn’t immediately open the box. Instead, he picked it up and inspected the exterior of the box while trying to guess what was inside.

He eventually gave up, as his anticipation was too high, so he opened it.

“T-This is...”

To Yuan’s absolute surprise and shock, there was a beautiful blue scale sitting inside this box!

“U-Unless my eyes are fooling me, this is the Flood Dragon’s scale! But how?! I thought Senior Nie was the one who won the auction!” He exclaimed the following moment.

Feng Yuxiang smiled, “There exists more than one Flood Dragon in this universe, you know? Also, a Flood Dragon has thousands of scales on its body. That means you can acquire thousands of scales for each Flood Dragon. Although they are rare, they aren’t that rare in the upper heavens—at least not in the way you are probably thinking.”

“A-Are you sure you want to give this to me— to Lulu? It’s worth at least 15 million spirit stones...” Yuan hesitated to accept the treasure due to its immense value.

“Of course. I have no use for it, anyway.” Feng Yuxiang nodded.

Chapter 726 - Using The Flood Dragon's Scale

"Hmm?" Seeing the Flood Dragon's scale, Yuan suddenly realized something.

"Wait a minute. Since a Flood Dragon has multiple scales, does this mean you were the one who sold that scale at the auction today? Feng Feng?"

"Eh?" Feng Yuxiang's face immediately turned stiff after hearing his words.

"N-No! I wasn't involved in the auction today!" She subconsciously responded.

"It was just a coincidence that they were selling a Flood Dragon's scale!"

Yuan nodded, "If you say so."

"Anyways, I am going to give this to Lulu."

Yuan went to knock on Chu Liuxiang's door and Feng Yuxiang sighed in relief when he didn't continue questioning her.

"What's up?" Chu Liuxiang stopped her cultivation to open the door.

"I have a surprise for you." Yuan said with a mysterious smile.

"A surprise for me? What is it?" Her eyes flickered with anticipation.

"Here." Yuan showed her the small box.

Chu Liuxiang raised her eyebrows when she saw this box, and she became speechless for a good moment.

"Did you get me an engagement ring?" She suddenly asked.

"Eh? N-Not exactly...?" Yuan said, dumbfounded by her response.

She chuckled, "I'm just joking with you. What's inside? Let me see..."

Chu Liuxiang opened the box a moment later, and her eyes widened with surprise when she saw what was in it.

"This is... Is this what I think it is?" she mumbled in a low voice.

"Yes, it's a Flood Dragon's scale."

"How on earth did you...?" Chu Liuxiang looked at him with her eyes wide as saucers.

"Actually, I wasn't the one who acquired it. You'll have to thank Feng Feng for that." Yuan said, and explained everything to her.

"Unbelievable... To think she also had one on her."

"It's not really that surprising now that I think about it. She used to own a very prestigious treasure store, and she came from the upper heavens." Yuan said.

"Where is she right now? I'd like to thank her."

"She's in the living room."

Chu Liuxiang approached Feng Yuxiang and bowed to her, "Thank you very much for this gift, Feng Feng."

"You're welcome."

"By the way, how do I use this scale?" Chu Liuxiang then asked.

"Well, it depends on what you want to use it for since there are multiple ways to prepare it."

"I'd like to use it to increase my innate talent," said Chu Liuxiang.

"I understand. Then allow me to help you."

"Please." Chu Liuxiang handed the Flood Dragon's scale back to her.

"Before we begin, I must warn you about something. The Flood Dragon is almost a divine beast with a powerful bloodline. Although you can still use the scale at your cultivation, it's going to be very painful. Do you wish to continue?"

"Yes, I don't care even if I have to endure a little pain." Chu Liuxiang nodded with a resolute face.

"Okay."

Feng Yuxiang left to prepare shortly after.

Sometime later, Feng Yuxiang returned to them and said, "Alright, the water is ready."

"Water?" Chu Liuxiang raised her eyebrows.

"Follow me."

Chu Liuxiang nodded and followed her. Yuan also followed because he was curious.

Feng Yuxiang led them to the bathroom a moment later.

"This is... Isn't this just body tempering?" Yuan asked when he saw the tub filled with boiling hot water.

"Not really." Feng Yuxiang shook her head, and she continued, "Although that's what it may seem like right now, it will be completely different once the real thing begins."

"Also, since the effect of the scale will only work once, do you want to improve the effects at the cost of it becoming more painful?"

"Huh?" Chu Liuxiang raised her eyebrows.

"Did you think you can continue using the Flood Dragon's scale to increase your talent without limit? It's already heaven-defying enough that you can improve your talent. With that being said, it'll only affect the Flood Dragon's scale. If you find another treasure that increases your talent, it will still work, but only one time."

Chu Liuxiang pondered for a moment before asking, "How much more painful...?"

"A lot."

Chu Liuxiang swallowed loudly. If she wasn't nervous before, she is now.

"I... I will do it!" She said after a moment of silence.

"Good. You can enter the bathtub whenever you're ready." Feng Yuxiang then said.

Chu Liuxiang quickly removed her clothes and approached the hot bath.

After taking a deep breath, she entered the bathtub.

"Hm? It's not that bad." Chu Liuxiang suddenly said in a surprised tone.

Feng Yuxiang smiled, "I didn't even put the Flood Dragon's scale into the water yet."

"Eh?" Chu Liuxiang's face flushed a little after hearing her words.

"Here, eat this pill. It'll increase the effects of the scale." Feng Yuxiang handed her a black pill the size of a tiny pebble.

Chu Liuxiang silently ate the pill after taking it.

The pill was a little bitter at first, but the aftertaste was quite minty.

"Are you ready?" Feng Yuxiang asked.

"I am."

Feng Yuxiang didn't say anything else and dropped the Flood Dragon's scale into the bathtub.

Immediately, the boiling water began cooling down at a rapid rate, and in just seconds, the water was filled with large chunks of ice.

"Aaaaah!" Chu Liuxiang suddenly screamed out loud, her voice filled with intense pain.

Yuan swallowed nervously when her scream caused his eardrums to tremble, and it made him recall his first time doing body temperament.

And after just a few seconds of being in the water, Chu Liuxiang jumped out before collapsing on the ground.

"Lulu?!" Yuan immediately went to check on her, and when he touched her body, it felt like he was touching a block of ice.

"It's too painful... I can't bear it..." Chu Liuxiang mumbled in a low voice as tears flowed from her face.

Chu Liuxiang isn't someone who has weak endurance. One can even say she has above-average endurance. However, the pain she felt when trying to absorb the treasure nearly made her insane.

"Of course it's painful. You're trying to improve your innate talents. In fact, it's much worse than body tempering." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Is there anything we can do to relieve her pain even slightly?" Yuan then asked.

Feng Yuxiang pondered for a moment before nodding her head, "There is a way, but you will be the one helping her, and it's going to be as painful for

you, Young Master."

"Me...?" Yuan swallowed nervously.

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Chapter 727 - Yin And Yang

"What do I need to do?" Yuan resolved himself after hearing that he could help Chu Liuxiang.

Feng Yuxiang retrieved another box from her spatial ring and handed it to him.

"Open it."

Yuan nodded and opened the box, and to his surprise, there was a scale inside. However, it was not the Flood Dragon's scale. This scale was bright red and emitting a fiery aura that made Yuan feel like his face was before an open oven that had its temperature maxed.

"What is this...?" Yuan looked at Feng Yuxiang as the hot air continued blowing into his face.

"That's an Inferno Dragon's scale. They're just like the Flood Dragon, but with a fire element. The Flood Dragon and the Inferno Dragon are like Yin and Yang with the Flood Dragon being Yin and the Inferno Dragon being Yang."

"Despite their different element that normally opposes each other, you can actually cultivate them together."

"If you cultivate the Inferno Dragon's scale while she cultivates the Flood Dragon's scale, you can ease each other's pain."

"However, since she has already absorbed a pill that enhances her effects, you will also have to do the same in order for this to work."

"It's going to be incredibly painful, Young Master. Do you still want to do it?"

"I will do it." He immediately nodded.

Not only will this benefit Chu Liuxiang, but it will also benefit him.

"Also you should know that the Inferno Dragon's scale will only affect those with fire spiritual veins. If you do not have such veins, you won't benefit from it." Feng Yuxiang suddenly said, leaving Yuan speechless.

He doesn't know his spiritual veins' element, and if this doesn't affect him, it would definitely suck for him. However, if it works on him, he will know that he has fire element spiritual veins.

"Regardless, I am doing this for Lulu. Even if I don't benefit from it, I am fine with it." Yuan eventually said.

"Okay. What about you? Do you want to continue? If you don't, there's no point in all of this." Feng Yuxiang asked Chu Liuxiang next.

"I... I want to continue." She said as she slowly stood back up.

"Good."

"Whenever you're ready, Young Master."

Yuan removed his clothes and entered the bathtub with Chu Liuxiang.

Feng Yuxiang then dropped the Inferno Dragon's scale inside the bathtub, and the icy water immediately began to melt, quickly becoming lukewarm.

"You can go ahead and start cultivating now," she said to them a moment later.

Yuan took a deep breath and started absorbing the treasure.

"Ah! It really freaking hurts!" Yuan exclaimed in a shocked voice.

He had underestimated the pain Chu Liuxiang felt before, but after experiencing it himself, he did not blame her for wanting to quit.

'And this is how it feels with the pain lowered? I cannot imagine it being any more painful than this!' Yuan cried inwardly.

Seeing Yuan's painful face, Chu Liuxiang took a moment to brace herself before she started absorbing the treasure again.

Intense pain immediately permeated throughout her body. Even though it wasn't as unbearably painful as before, it was still painful enough to knock most people unconscious if they experienced it.

However, she wasn't the only one suffering this time, and Yuan was enduring the same pain just for her, so she couldn't give up no matter how painful it was.

"Young Master, slow down on your side. If you absorb the treasure too quickly, the Yin and Yang will become unbalanced, and it will only get more painful from there." Feng Yuxiang warned him.

Yuan silently nodded and controlled his pace until it matched Chu Liuxiang's pace.

"I know it's very painful, but at least it'll be done within an hour if you continue at your pace." Feng Yuxiang said a moment later.

An hour would usually disappear very quickly, especially when they're focused, but this time it was different.

The sensation of pain made them count every second even if they didn't want to, making it feel longer than reality.

However, despite feeling similar levels of pain, both Yuan and Chu Liuxiang were having polar opposite experiences.

Chu Liuxiang was assaulted by an extremely cold sensation while feeling like her spiritual veins were being stabbed all over by sharp icicles.

Meanwhile, Yuan felt like he was being baked inside an oven, and his internal organs and blood felt like it was engulfed in flames.

It felt like they were living in separate versions of hell.

"It's almost been an hour... I wonder if the Inferno Dragon's scale will affect the Young Master, and if it does, how much will it increase his talents." Feng Yuxiang mumbled to herself.

"A tiny percentage of Brother Yuan's talent is enough to make even a once-in-a-century genius look like an ordinary cultivator..." Xiao Hua said.

"Yes, that's why I am excited. What will happen if he happens to have fire element spiritual veins?"

A couple more minutes later, Yuan slowly opened his eyes and took a long and deep breath.

Ding!

<Your resistance to pain has increased significantly>

"Lulu, are you okay?" Yuan asked her.

"Yes, I am fine. Just a little exhausted, that's all."

They left the bathtub shortly after.

After they got dressed, Feng Yuxiang asked them, "How do you feel?"

"Umm... I can't really tell... Are we supposed to feel any different?" Yuan asked.

"Not really. As long as you don't feel any post-pain or sickness, it means you'd successfully managed to absorb the treasure."

"I thought body tempering was the most painful thing in the world, but my experience today proved me wrong..." Yuan sighed.

Feng Yuxiang smiled and said, "If you think this is painful, just wait until you experience treasures that are far more potent than the scales. Although they are considered as heavenly treasures in this world, they are only low-grade treasures in the upper heavens."

Yuan swallowed nervously after hearing her words.

"Anyways, let's rest here for today. We'll return to Min tomorrow.." He then said.

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Chapter 728 - Ascending Together

Yuan and Chu Liuxiang logged off the game shortly after they finished absorbing the dragon scales.

"What the? The bed is wet?!" Chu Liuxiang sat up in a surprised manner after feeling a wet sensation on her back, wondering if they'd pissed themselves by accident.

However, she quickly realized that it wasn't the bed that was wet—it was her pajamas, and her body was also soaked in sweat as well.

"Did absorbing the treasure in cultivation online make us sweat?" Yuan wondered out loud.

"It's possible, since the sensation of pain we felt was so incredibly real that it'd affected our real body." Chu Liuxiang said.

"I'm going to wash up."

Chu Liuxiang said, and she continued, "You can join me whenever."

"I am going to change the bed sheets before I go." Yuan said.

Chu Liuxiang entered the bathroom a moment later while Yuan replaced the bedsheets with new ones before joining Chu Liuxiang in the bathroom.

"Let me wash your back." Chu Liuxiang said to him.

"Thank you."

"No, I should be thanking you. If you didn't help me with the Flood Dragon's scale today, I would have not been able to absorb it, and I

would've wasted a very precious treasure." She sighed.

"I'd gladly do it again if it's for you." Yuan smiled.

"..."

Chu Liuxiang suddenly turned silent.

"You know, if you say stuff like that, it makes me want to embrace you," she suddenly said.

Yuan began blushing when he heard words, which reminded his experience with Meixiu.

After a moment of silence, Chu Liuxiang said, "By the way, I have decided to visit my parents tomorrow. I want to tell them my feelings as soon as possible and get it out of my chest."

"Do you want me to come with you?" Yuan then asked.

"No, I will go alone. However, if I don't return..."

"You think they'll force you to stay?"

"I don't need to think about it. There's a very good chance that they won't let me return after I tell them my feelings, but who knows, a miracle could happen."

"Don't worry, if they don't let you leave, I will take you back myself as long as you want me to."

"I want to return to your side." Chu Liuxiang said.

"That's all I need to know." Yuan smiled.

After they finished washing, they went downstairs to see if Meixiu needed help with preparing dinner.

"Looks like you had a breakthrough. Congratulations." Yuan said to her when he noticed a chance in her aura.

"Thank you."

"We participated in an auction today. I wanted to invite you, but I didn't want to disturb your cultivation."

"What did you buy?" She then asked.

"Nothing. The treasure being sold was too expensive for us. It sold for twenty million spirit stones, which is about 200 billion gold coins!"

Meixiu's eyes widened with surprise.

"200 billion? That's a lot of money... What was sold?"

"A treasure called Flood Dragon's scale. It belongs to a powerful magical beast from the upper heavens." Yuan recalled the auction for Meixiu.

"By the way, Feng Feng also happened to have a Flood Dragon's scale, and she gave it to Lulu, who has water spiritual veins, allowing her to improve her innate talent."

Sometime later, Meixiu said, "Since I won't breakthrough for a while, I can start playing with you again."

"That sounds good." Yuan nodded.

Once dinner was ready, everybody sat around the dinner table.

"Yuan, I am going to ascend to Spirit Heaven tomorrow. Where should I meet you?" Wang Ming asked him as they ate.

"Once you ascend the Stairway to Heaven, you will be transported to this square. You can just wait for me there and I will come pick you up. We can visit the Myriad of Techniques afterward to get you some new techniques." Yuan said.

"Okay."

"Anyone else also ascending tomorrow?" Yuan then asked the others.

Four other people raised their hands, and they were Wang Bingbing, Shi Lang, Hong Xiuquan, and Li Jinxi.

"What about the two of you?" Yuan asked Xi Murong and Wu Zao.

"I will go next week," said Xi Murong.

"Me too."

"Alright." Yuan nodded.

"Since we're all going, we might as well ascend together." Wang Wang suggested a moment later, and they all agreed.

"Then we'll all meet up after morning practice."

"I will meet you guys sometime at noon since we're a couple of hours away from that place." Yuan said.

"Take your time." Wang Ming nodded.

After cleaning up, everyone returned to their room.

The following morning, Yuan and Chu Liuxiang made their journey back to Min Li with everyone else.

"Aren't you going to visit your parents today?" Yuan asked Chu Liuxiang before they left.

"I will do that after we meet up with Meixiu in the other city," she said.

Many hours later, they arrived at the hotel, and Min Li was casually sipping tea in the living room.

"Welcome back. How was the auction?" Min Li said to them.

"It was crazy. We didn't manage to buy the treasure, by the way." Yuan said with a smile.

"That's unfortunate."

"Congratulations on the breakthrough, though."

"Thank you. It happened only an hour ago, so you returned at the perfect time. What are our plans now?" Min Li then asked.

"I am going to meet with a few friends back at the city before this one. We still have to pick up Meixiu there before we can go anywhere."

"When do we leave?"

"We'll leave now if you're ready."

"I am." Min Li nodded.

"Great. Then let's go."

After checking out of the hotel, they left the city.

Half an hour later, they returned to their original location and met up with Meixiu, who was still living inside their old hotel.

"I am going to meet up with a few of my friends now. You guys can wait here since I won't be gone for long." Yuan said to them.

"I am going to visit my parents now." Chu Liuxiang said.

"Okay. If you don't return by tomorrow, I will be giving the Chu Family a visit." Yuan nodded.

Chu Liuxiang logged off the game and began making her way to the upper levels of the Dragon Spiral Mountain, where her Chu Family was located.

Chapter 729 - Come Meet Me As Soon As Possible

After Chu Liuxiang logged off, Yuan prepared to meet with Wang Ming and the others.

"Young Master, what about us?" Feng Yuxiang asked him.

"It's going to be crowded, so it would be better if you stayed here as well." Yuan said.

"I can just enter your body if it's crowded." She said.

"Oh, right, you can do that... Well, it's up to you."

Feng Yuxiang didn't say anything else and entered his body.

Xiao Hua also did the same since she'd rather not stay behind while Feng Yuxiang went with him.

"Do you want to come as well?" Yuan asked Meixiu.

"Yes."

"Alright. We should be back by tonight." Yuan said to Min Li.

"You don't need to worry about me. Even though I just had a breakthrough, cultivation never ends," she said with a smile.

Yuan nodded, and he left the hotel with Meixiu shortly after to meet up with Wang Ming and the others.

Sometime later, they arrived at the square where people that leave the Stairway to Heaven gather, and sure enough, there were still new players that had decided to ascend from the Lower Heavens appearing in the square every few minutes.

"Do you see them?" Yuan asked Meixiu as they walked around the massive square that was also crowded with people.

"No... Oh? I think that's them over there." Meixiu pointed at a certain group of individuals, and these people appeared to be in a fight.

"Are they fighting?!" Yuan was shocked to see this.

He immediately rushed to them, but he quickly realized that it was a misunderstanding and that they were just sparring with each other.

"What are you guys doing, sparring with each other in the middle of a city?" Yuan asked them with a helpless look on his face.

Just how much do they love training? They were like a bunch of addicts that cannot stop training or they'll die.

"Hm? Oh, you're finally here. We got bored of waiting, so we started sparring with each other." Wang Ming said with a smile on his face.

"I told you that I would come at noon, right? Why didn't you just do something else till then? Hell, you could've trained in the field at home."

"That won't do. We won't last a minute sparring with Li Jinxi outside. However, we can defeat her with ease in Cultivation Online." Wang Ming laughed out loud.

Yuan raised his eyebrows and turned to look at Li Jinxi, who was sitting on the ground not far away, seemingly exhausted.

"You don't get to see such a sight often, right?" Wang Ming chuckled.

"I guess so..." Yuan nodded in a dazed manner.

"Anyways, now that I am here, let's head to the Myriad of Techniques." Yuan said to them a moment later.

Once they were prepared, the group began following Yuan.

"So you're all Spirit Warriors, huh?" Yuan noticed their aura.

"We were only Spirit Apprentices not long ago. Most of us were below fourth level since we didn't play much then." Shi Lang said.

"Huh? How did you all level up this fast?" Yuan was curious.

"We purchased a lot of treasures with real money." Wang Ming said without a shred of shame on his face.

"It was quite expensive, you know? It took us almost 100 million each to reach Spirit Warrior."

Yuan shook his head with a smile and said, "Spirit Warrior is just the beginning. Although there is nothing wrong with paying for your levels since everybody does it in this world as well, in the form of buying treasures to assist their cultivation, don't expect that it will be as effective in the future. It will become super expensive really quickly."

"We know. We just needed to boost ourselves so that we're not completely behind." Wang Bingbing said.

Sometime later, they arrived at the Myriad of Techniques.

Once they entered the store, someone checked their destiny, and the Divine Crystal of Heavenly Fortune deemed them all to have a minor destiny.

"Do you guys have any techniques that you want in mind? If not, we can head to the fourth floor, where all of the Heaven-rank techniques are located."

"Heaven-rank techniques? Aren't they going to be really expensive?" Wang Bingbing asked.

"Normally, but I can get them for free since I am part of the faction that runs this place." Yuan said.

"What? If that's the case, let us join too! Where do we go to sign up?" Wang Ming said in an excited voice.

"You don't exactly sign up for it... And I was offered to join by someone in the upper heavens. I don't think they exist in this world." Yuan shook his head.

"So you've been to the upper heavens already?" Shi Lang looked at him with a surprised face.

"Not exactly. The place we met was in a different dimension that didn't exist within the Nine Heavens, so it wasn't like I went up there to speak with them."

"Though I will speak with them the next chance I get and see if you guys can join as well." Yuan said.

"That's good enough for me." Wang Ming nodded.

After arriving at the fourth floor, Wang Ming and the others scattered to look for a technique of their suiting.

"What about you, Meixiu?" Yuan asked her, who stayed behind with him.

"You only have a movement technique, right? Why don't you find a new technique— one that you can use to protect yourself?"

"I will go look around." Meixiu nodded and went to look for a technique as well.

While Yuan waited, he suddenly heard a voice resound in his head.

"Yuan, come meet me as soon as possible."

"Senior Bai?" Yuan immediately recognized his calming voice, but it sounded urgent.

After looking for Meixiu and letting her know that he will be gone for a bit, Yuan went to seek Senior Bai in his dimension.

A few minutes later, he entered Senior Bai's dimension and flew towards the platform they usually met at, and sure enough, Senior Bai was standing there with a pondering expression on his face as he stared at the horizon.

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Chapter 730 - Returning To The Chu Family

"Senior Bai, it's been a while." Yuan greeted him with a bow once the landed on the platform.

Senior Bai turned around to face him with a smile that looked slightly forced.

"The passage of time is different for someone like me, and time feels slower than in reality. One day might feel like one day to you, but for someone like me, one day feels like a few minutes."

"Did something happen? You seem worried." Yuan decided to ask him.

"Take a seat." Senior Bai pointed at the chair.

Yuan nodded, and they sat down a moment later.

Meanwhile, Chu Liuxiang had just arrived at the Chu Family's household.

"This place looks gloomier than it does in my memories..." Chu Liuxiang sighed inwardly as she approached the massive steel gate that surrounded the Chu Family's territory.

After pressing the call button on the device at the gates, she waited for someone from the inside to answer it.

"Hello, this is the Chu Family. Who am I speaking with?" A feminine voice resounded a moment later.

"It's me. Hurry up and open the doors so I can speak with my parents." Chu Liuxiang said out loud.

"Y-Young Lady?! Please wait a minute while I call a ride for you!" The person on the other side immediately recognized her just by her voice alone.

The gates immediately opened, and Chu Liuxiang entered into their territory without saying anything else, but she didn't go any further, as the actual building was a couple of miles away from the gates.

After two minutes of waiting, a limousine pulled up beside her, and an old woman came out of the car to open the door for her.

"Welcome back, Young Lady." The old woman bowed to her.

"I'm not back." Chu Liuxiang casually responded.

"..."

The old woman didn't have any response for such words, so she decided to remain silent.

Sometime later, they arrived in front of this massive mansion that looked more like a castle than a house a couple of miles away from the gates.

"Welcome home, Young Lady."

Two rows of servants were already prepared to welcome her back at the front door.

Once they entered the building, Chu Liuxiang could see Sebastian standing not far away.

"Young Lady, the Masters are waiting for you in the family hall," he said to her.

Chu Liuxiang nodded silently and made her way to this family hall with Sebastian and the old woman following her from behind.

"We will be waiting outside." Sebastian said to her once they arrived outside the room.

Chu Liuxiang opened the door and entered the room with a resolute expression on her face.

The moment she entered the room, she could see two individuals— a handsome middle-aged man and a beautiful woman who didn't look any older than her twenties.

These two individuals were clearly her parents. Her father, Chu Shijian, and her mother, Chu Shufen.

"Looks like you have finally decided to listen to your parents and return to the family. I'm relieved." Chu Shijian said to her, assuming that she had agreed to return to the family.

Unfortunately, they are only moments away from immense disappointment.

"I'm sorry to tell you this, father, but I did not come back here because I want to return to the family," Chu Liuxiang said with a stern expression on her face.

"Then why are you here?" As expected, Chu Shijian immediately became displeased after hearing her words.

"I am here to tell you my feelings and plan."

Chu Liuxiang proceeded to take a long and deep breath before continuing, "I want to start a family with Yuan, so I cannot return to this family."

"You what?!" Both of her parents exclaimed in a shocked voice at the same time.

"That's outrageous!" Chu Shijian said.

And he continued, "You only knew that man for a few years in an orphanage when you were still a child! There's no way that you actually like him! You're confused right now, my dear!"

"Your father is right, Liuxiang. You might think that you're feeling love, but that is not the case. I know because I was once in your shoes. However, once I grew up and understood the world more, I realized that 'love' I felt was merely an illusion that will quickly go away once you understand your own feelings more." Her mother also gave her options on the matter.

"You're wrong, father, mother. I know my feelings very well. I love him, and I want to be with him for the rest of my life. Nobody in this world makes me feel the way he does. I feel safe when I am with him, and I am never bored when I am with him no matter what mundane things we do." Chu Liuxiang refuted their claims.

"Why are you not happy for me? Yuan is not only very talented, he's also destined for great things! I know you want me to marry into an influential family, but Yuan will surpass every single one of these families that you're planning to match with me!"

"Hell, he even has the Six Spiritual Families' approval and backing! That alone should qualify him as my husband!"

Chu Shijian shook his head and said, "This world is not just about one's backing, dear. Even if it is, he only has the Six Spiritual Families' backing. While the Six Spiritual Families are, without a doubt, a force to be reckoned with, they are nothing more than cowards that lived the last few thousands of years in hiding— in fear."

"Furthermore, there is nothing to gain from befriending them."

Chu Liuxiang closed her eyes and sighed in a dispirited voice, "In the end, it's all about profits, huh? Yuan... He had to endure a decade of abuse in the Yu Family because they wanted to profit off him. I thought my family was better than that, but alas, it appears that you're not that different from the Yu Family after all..."

Chapter 731 - Senior Qi

Bang!

Chu Shijian suddenly slammed his fist into his chair rest after hearing Chu Liuxiang's words that compared them to the Yu Family, his face fuming with anger.

"How dare you compare us to that disgraceful place! We're nothing like the Yu Family! Not only did we treat you like a princess, but we also exhausted countless resources into you just so that you can be at where you are today! If we didn't save you from that orphanage, god knows where you would be right now!"

"And I am supposed to be grateful for that? Did you forget why you adopted me in the first place? If it were not for my cultivation talents, you wouldn't even have batted an eye at me! If you did not plan on profiting off me by selling me to some family that I don't want to be with, you wouldn't have treated me so nicely! Tell me that I am wrong, father!" Chu Liuxiang argued back.

Although Chu Liuxiang and her father often argued with each other, it never became this serious, and they would end up joking with each other at the end.

By now, Chu Shijian's entire body was trembling from anger. If his eyes could produce fire, it would be spewing them by now.

"Calm down." Chu Shufen said in a soothing voice as she placed her hand onto his fist.

Although she'd managed to stop his shaking, his face was still twisted in anger.

She then looked at Chu Liuxiang and spoke, "Liuxiang, you claim that you love him, but that is just your words and not your actual feelings—"

"That is my actual feelings!" Chu Liuxiang interrupted.

And she continued, "I also doubted my feelings for him at first, but that's why I went to find him! The moment I saw his face, even though it has been over 10 years since I last saw him, I knew at that very moment that I really loved him!"

"However, I continued to follow him to verify my feelings for him, and every single day I spent with him, my conviction grew stronger and stronger!"

Chu Shufen shook her head and sighed, "You don't have to say anything else, Liuxiang. You're going to forget about him once you join a real family — one that we are sure will perfectly suit you."

"I refuse!" Chu Liuxiang stood her ground.

"Unfortunately, this isn't a matter where you have a choice. Until we find you a family, we forbid you from leaving the garden— your home."

Hearing her mother's words, Chu Liuxiang released her Spirit Master cultivation base.

"What do you think you're doing? Are you threatening us? Did you already forget that you're not the only Spirit Master in this household?" Chu Shufen said as she released her aura, which was even more powerful than Chu Liuxiang's aura.

Chu Liuxiang gritted her teeth, as she was aware that she wouldn't be able to defeat her parents in her current state.

However, Chu Shufen suddenly withdrew her aura and said in a loud voice, "Senior Qi, please take her back to the garden for us."

"W-What did you just say?" Chu Liuxiang's eyes widened with shock when she heard the name 'Senior Qi'.

A figure appeared before Chu Liuxiang the next moment, and she was an extremely beautiful woman that looked only slightly older than Chu Liuxiang.

She had long black hair that flowed down her back until it reached her round buttocks. Her cleavage was also quite impressive in the way that it looked completely flawless no matter which angle one looked from. She was also wearing traditional robes that made her look like a cultivator at glance, and if she were to stand beside the cultivators inside Cultivation Online, one would not be able to tell any difference between them whether it was their demeanor or aura.

"Master... What are you doing here? I thought you had some important matters and could not return for many years..." Chu Liuxiang muttered in a low voice.

This woman Chu Liuxiang called 'Master' was actually her teacher, who taught her everything about cultivation.

"I heard that you were causing trouble again, so I decided to come back. Come with me. Let's talk about it." Senior Qi said to her, and she began walking towards the door without looking back to see if Chu Liuxiang would follow her.

Chu Liuxiang glared at her parents for a moment before following Senior Qi, leaving the scene shortly after.

Sometime later, Chu Liuxiang followed Senior Qi to this large garden behind the Chu Family's household, and there was even an immortal cave beside a clear pond.

"Sit down." Senior Qi suddenly stopped walking in front of the pond and said without turning back.

Chu Liuxiang didn't say anything and obediently took a seat seiza-style on the soft ground.

"Tell me everything that has happened. Start from when you left the family." Senior Qi then said as she continued to stare into the pond.

Chu Liuxiang nodded and began recalling her experience to Senior Qi.

Meanwhile, inside Cultivation Online, Yuan and Senior Bai just sat down.

"Do you know of a place called the Nine Heavens Eternal Grotto?" Senior Bai suddenly asked him after a moment of awkward silence.

"No, I do not." Yuan quickly shook his head.

"It's one of the most dangerous places in the Nine Heavens that has existed even before the Primordial Era. However, it's not dangerous in the way you're probably thinking. The reason it's so dangerous is because of the criminals that are imprisoned there."

"Criminals?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"Yes, incredibly dangerous criminals that are also Immortals that cannot be destroyed through normal means, hence why they were tossed inside the Nine Heavens Eternal Grotto for all eternity. The Nine Heavens Eternal Grotto is a place where once someone enters, they will not be able to escape no matter if they are Immortal or God. However, that is only from the inside, meaning it can still be opened from the outside."

"I... I don't like where this is going..." Yuan said with a frown on his face.

Chapter 732 - Escaped Immortals

"If you're thinking that someone had opened the Nine Heavens Eternal Grotto, then you're right, unfortunately." Senior Bai sighed.

"Shouldn't there be someone to guard that place? It would be disastrous if the criminals inside escaped, or am I wrong?" Yuan asked.

"No, you're right. However, there are people guarding the grotto. In fact, there are at least a dozen Immortals guarding that place around the clock, and there hasn't been a single moment when the grotto isn't guarded since the Primordial Era."

"Then how did someone open the grotto?"

"Simple. Someone managed to kill the guards and open the grotto."

"So all of the criminals inside are free now?" Yuan then asked.

"No, not all, which is the most fortunate part in all of this. Although the perpetrator managed to open the grotto, it was only for a brief moment, as the guards were able to call for backup before they died."

"However, that brief moment had allowed 4 incredibly dangerous criminals to escape."

"The entire upper heavens are on the lookout for these criminals right now, but none of the criminals have been caught yet."

Hearing his words, Yuan sighed, "Since you called me here... Do you want me to capture these criminals or something?"

Senior Bai looked at him with wide eyes.

After a moment of silence, he burst out laughing.

"Of course not! You're only a Spirit Lord while these criminals are all Immortals that have existed since the Primordial Era. You will die before you can even touch them."

"Then why did you call me here?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"I just wanted to warn you about the current situation in the upper heavens, and although very unlikely, these criminals could escape to the lower heavens." Senior Bai said.

"Even if they escape to the lower heavens, how will I be able to identify them when I don't even know them?" Yuan then asked.

Senior Bai retrieved a red crystal and handed it to him.

"All criminals in the grotto have a seal in their soul that cannot be removed, and as long as they're within 1 mile of this crystal, it will begin reacting to its seal. That's how you know there's a criminal nearby." Senior Bai said.

"If that happens, I want you to report it to me so that we can come to you. Don't even think about confronting these people by yourself. You'll, without a doubt, die."

Yuan nodded, "I won't. I am not that reckless."

"Here's a jade slip that you can use to contact me. The moment you activate it using your spiritual energy, it will notify me, and I will come to you. However, since I am in the upper heavens, it will take some time for me to get there."

Senior Bai handed him a jade slip.

Ding!

<You have been given a Faction Quest by an Overlord!>

[Faction Quest: Escaped Immortals]

[Difficulty: Impossible]

[Description: Report, catch, or kill all four criminals that escaped from the Nine Heavens Eternal Grotto]

[Reward: ???]

"Also, here's a life-saving treasure for you just in case. As long as you have it in your body, it will be able to protect you from any grievous injuries once— even if it was given to you by an immortal."

"Thank you." Yuan accepted the life-saving treasure which was a small crystal ball that contained some sort of red liquid within.

"Eat it." Senior Bai said to him afterward.

"Eh?" Yuan raised his eyebrows. This is his first time seeing a life-saving treasure that required consumption.

"This life-saving treasure is a little different compared to your ordinary life-saving treasure in the way it functions. Normal life-saving treasures will protect you from harm. However, this life-saving treasure will basically give you a second life, but it will not protect you from harm."

"I understand." Yuan nodded his head before tossing the treasure inside his mouth like it was a monster core.

Ding!

<You have consumed a 'Phoenix Rebirth Pill'>

"Phoenix Rebirth Pill?" Yuan mumbled in a low voice.

"Indeed. It was crafted with phoenix blood and many other priceless treasures. There are not many of them out there."

"T-Thank you for giving me such a priceless treasure!" Yuan immediately bowed to him.

Senior Bai smiled and said, "Consider it a gift for ranking up in the faction."

"Eh? How did you know?" Yuan was surprised that he knew about it.

"Did you forget my identity? I can tell your faction rank the moment I look at you."

"By the way, speaking about the faction, my friends would like to join the faction as well. Is that possible?"

"Your friends, huh? In order to join the faction, they must pass our test, but this test can only be done in the Fifth Heaven and above. Therefore, they must climb to the Fifth Heaven in order to join. This is a rule that even I cannot do anything about. The reason you were able to join is because of Xu Jiaqi, who is a Celestial Overlord, allowing her to bend the rules to some extent."

"I see... I will let them know." Yuan said.

"Good. Now, before I let you go, may I speak with a certain someone in your body? More specifically, the lass from the Primordial Realm." Senior Bai suddenly narrowed his eyes.

Yuan's eyes widened with surprise, and he asked in a nervous voice, "Senior Bai... Why do you want to speak with Xiao Hua?"

"Calm down, I am not going to harm her." Senior Bai smiled.

"It's okay, Brother Yuan."

Xiao Hua's voice resounded as she materialized beside him.

"What do you want from Xiao Hua?" She asked him with a calm face, yet her heart was beating nervously.

After all, Senior Bai could easily kill her if he wished, and she would have no way to defend herself.

"So you're the exile that has been following my little friend here, huh? Since your surname is 'Xiao', are you perhaps from the Asura Clan?" Senior Bai asked her.

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Chapter 733 - Asura Clan

Xiao Hua's body trembled when she heard the name 'Asura Clan' come out of Senior Bai's mouth.

"You know Xiao Hua's family?" She asked him.

Senior Bai chuckled for a moment before shaking his head, "No, I don't personally know them, but who in the Nine Heavens hasn't heard of the infamous Asura Clan? Everyone born within that family is exceptionally talented, not to mention their heaven-defying physiques that give them an indestructible body."

"The Nine Heavens respected... feared the Asura Clan."

"Young lady, your family was banished to the Primordial Realm for a reason. Why do you want to set them free? What does your family plan on doing once they return?" Senior Bai was well aware of her Legacy and its purpose.

However, he does not know of Xiao Hua or her family's purpose.

"Xiao Hua does not know," she responded to him in a clear voice, indicating that she truly doesn't know her family's plan, nor why she's helping them.

Senior Bai narrowed his eyes at Xiao Hua before shifting his gaze to Yuan.

"The Primordial Realm isn't any better than the Nine Heavens Grotto, as they both serve the same purpose. However, there is a slight difference between the two. The Primordial Realm was created to punish those that have wronged, but they are not hopeless. As long as they fulfill the Supreme Heaven's Legacy, they may roam the land freely."

"As for the Nine Heavens Eternal Grotto, once you're inside, it is impossible to come back out unless someone is daring enough to break you out."

"If the heavens are willing to give your family a second chance, I have no right to interfere with your legacy. However, not everyone shares the same sentiment as me."

"Some people out there have made it their lifelong mission to prevent those from the Primordial Realm from regaining their freedom, so it won't be easy. Although you won't meet any of these people right now, once you climb higher, where more people recognize her aura..."

"Her aura?" Yuan looked at Xiao Hua with raised eyebrows.

"I don't sense anything unnatural about her aura."

"Of course you don't. You have never met another exile in your life. Exiles have this unique aura that can be sensed by those with a superior divine sense, which you'll get once you reach Spirit Sovereign. However, knowing you, you'll probably learn it at a much earlier stage, perhaps as a Spirit Emperor." Senior Bai explained.

"Spirit Sovereigns can only be found in the Fifth Heaven and above. I hope you'll be ready then, because that is where her legacy truly makes it impossible. Of course, you can still choose to leave her. That's what Xu Jiaqi would suggest you do."

"That will never happen. Even if I have to fight the entire world, I won't abandon her." Yuan said with a stern face.

"Suit yourself." Senior Bai shrugged.

"Anyways, I have kept you here for long enough. Just remember to keep a lookout for the escaped immortals. If they're not caught soon, they will terrorize the world, and many innocent lives will be lost."

"I will let you know if I encounter them." Yuan nodded.

"Good. Then I will see you later."

Yuan and Xiao Hua left the place shortly after.

Senior Bai sighed to himself after they left, "The Asura Clan... They were once respected and admired by the entire Nine Heavens. But after their sudden rampage and their affiliation with 'that person' was exposed, they became the most feared family in the Nine Heavens."

"In the entire Nine Heavens, there are only a handful of people who wouldn't mind the Asura Clan regaining their freedom. Good luck, Yuan."

After returning to the Myriad of Techniques, Yuan sat down with Xiao Hua at an empty table.

"If you don't want to talk about it, you don't need to." Yuan said to her after a moment of silence.

Xiao Hua bit her lips and said, "Xiao Hua doesn't know why her family was banished to the Primordial Realm, and no matter how many times I ask my family, they would not tell me."

"However, they would always say that they weren't wrong for what they did and that they did not regret their actions even slightly."

Yuan smiled and said, "If they managed to raise someone like you, I don't doubt that whatever they did, they truly believed in their purpose. They are probably good people that made a mistake. Everyone makes mistakes no matter how perfect they may seem."

Xiao Hua shook her head and said, "Xiao Hua's family are not good people. They have killed a lot of people, and they never smile."

"I will be the judge of that when we meet them." Yuan said.

"Un." Xiao Hua nodded her head before returning inside his body.

Sometime later, Meixiu and the others began returning one by one with a technique in their grasp.

Both Wang Ming and Wang Bingbing decided to pick a sword technique while Shi Lang picked a spear technique. As for Hong Xiuquan and Li Jinxi, they also picked a technique that benefited their weapon of choice. Of course, they were all Heaven-rank techniques.

"What did you get?" Yuan asked Meixiu, who was the last to return.

"It's a bow technique that was once used by a famous archer, who managed to pierce a star with this very technique— at least that's what the description said."

"Alright. Since everyone has their techniques now, let's check out."

Thus, they returned back to the first floor to 'pay' for the techniques.

"All done. You still have 6 free techniques for this year." The young man said after logging in their techniques into the logbook.

"Thank you."

Once everyone had their technique, Yuan and the others left the Myriad of Techniques.

"Thanks for the technique, Yuan. I am going to study the hell out of it to show my gratitude!" Wang Ming said to him after they left.

"Don't train too hard. I'm afraid that you'll break something if you train any more than you already are.." Yuan smiled.

Chapter 734 - Waited All Night

"We're going to practice our techniques at the Cultivators' Haven if they have one here. What are you going to do, Yuan? Want to come with us?" Wang Ming asked him sometime later.

"Sorry but I have other plans. But if you ever need me, just let me know." Yuan shook his head.

"Alright. Once again, thank you for these techniques."

"Wait. Before you go, I have one last thing for you." Yuan retrieved another technique and handed it to Wang Ming.

"This is a Heaven-rank technique called 'Demon Sealing Strike'. It can only be used with a sword, but it will allow you to seal demons if you hit them with this technique. After you learn it, hand it to Wang Bingbing and Li Jinxi so that they can also learn it."

Yuan then looked at Hong Xiuquan and continued, "I don't have any other demon sealing technique at this moment that works for your type of weapon, but once I find something, I will let you learn it as well."

"No problem." Hong Xiuquan nodded.

"Guess I will have to put my own technique on hold for now until I finish learning this Demon Sealing Technique." Wang Ming said.

Sometime later, Yuan and Meixiu returned to the hotel while the others went to study their new techniques.

"Alas, the situation with the escaped immortals sound like a pain in the ass. I hope they catch them soon." Yuan sighed once they returned.

"Escaped immortals?" Meixiu raised her eyebrows.

"Well..." Yuan proceeded to explain the situation to her.

"That does sound troublesome..." Meixiu sighed.

"Fortunately, it is very unlikely that we will meet them since they're mostly in the upper heavens." Yuan said.

Sometime later, Meixiu asked, "What are we going to do now, Yuan? More specifically what are your plans?"

"I will figure something out tomorrow once Lulu returns."

"Speaking of Chu Liuxiang... She mentioned something about returning home?" Meixiu said.

"Yes, she went back home to speak with her parents. She should return by tonight."

"Okay."

"Since there isn't anything else to do, I'll log off for today."

"Wait, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang suddenly appeared before him right as he prepared to log off.

"Feng Feng?"

"Young Master, I'd like to request for some of your blood," she said with a solemn expression on her face.

"Oh? You finally cannot resist your urges? I thought you'd forgotten about it." Yuan smiled at her request.

"It's not that, Young Master. After hearing about the escaped immortals, I figured that it would be for the best if I release my curse even if it's just a little. I don't want to be powerless when you need me."

"Regardless of your reason, if you want my blood, you just need to ask me. I promised to help you remove that curse, after all."

Yuan extended his hand to her and said, "Go ahead. Drink as much as you want."

"Thank you, Young Master."

Feng Yuxiang grabbed his hand before opening her mouth and putting his finger inside.

She then bit a hole in his finger to release blood, but Yuan didn't feel any pain, and it felt more like a nibble.

Yuan swallowed nervously after watching Feng Yuxiang suck on his finger. This wasn't Feng Yuxiang's first time sucking his blood, and he never had such a reaction before, so why is his body suddenly heating up now?

He eventually realized that it was because of Feng Yuxiang's mouth, as the sensation from it reminded him of something else.

In order to calm his mind, Yuan began reciting all the array symbols inside his head.

About a minute later, Feng Yuxiang opened her mouth and released a satisfied sigh, sounding like someone who just finished chugging down an amazing drink.

Her hair began changing colors, becoming fiery red. Her eyes also turned golden, and she stared at Yuan's finger with an allured expression, seemingly not satisfied despite drinking a mouthful of his blood already.

She quickly shook her head and clapped her own cheeks to snap herself out of her temptation.

"You can drink more if you want." Yuan noticed that she wasn't satisfied.

"No, if I continue, I will surpass Spirit King and be forced to ascend." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Spirit King...?" It was at this moment Yuan realized that Feng Yuxiang's aura had skyrocketed from peak Spirit Grandmaster to Spirit King!

In fact, her aura is even stronger than Xiao Hua's at this moment!

"Although I am still nowhere near strong enough to fight Immortals, we should be fine for a while." Feng Yuxiang said with a smile.

"If you need more blood, just let me know." Yuan nodded.

"I will. Thank you, Young Master. My shoulders feel a lot lighter now that my curse has been weakened even more."

"I'm glad to hear that."

Yuan and Meixiu logged off the game shortly after.

Meixiu went to cook dinner immediately afterward, as it was already evening by the time they logged off.

"She's not back yet..." Yuan mumbled in a low voice when he woke up in an empty room.

He had gotten so used to waking up with Chu Liuxiang right beside him that it now feels awkward waking up alone.

Sometime later, he went downstairs for dinner.

"Hmm? Where is Miss Chu?" Wang Ming asked Yuan since they would always show up together.

"She returned to her family temporarily to speak with her parents." Yuan said.

"She should return later tonight."

"I see."

After dinner, Yuan returned to his room, but he didn't sleep and patiently waited all night for Chu Liuxiang to return.

However, Chu Liuxiang never returned from her family.

When the sun began rising, Yuan released a low sigh,? "I really wanted things to be different this time. Why can't parents just let their children decide on their own future? Why must they make things difficult for us?"

Yuan stood up and left the house without letting anyone know, as he didn't want to worry them, and he began making his way to the upper levels in the Dragon Spiral Mountain with a slight frown on his face.

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Chapter 735 - Visiting The Chu Family

Although Yuan wasn't sure where he was going, nor where the Chu Family was located, he knew that they were in the upper levels of the mountain.

After walking for about half an hour, Yuan came across his first building to the Chu Family, and he decided to ask the people living there if they knew where the Chu Family lived.

A maid answered the door a few moments after Yuan knocked on their doors.

"Hello? How can we help you, young man?"

Yuan greeted the old woman with a charming smile, "Good morning, madam. I'm sorry for disturbing your family so early in the morning. I am supposed to meet a friend in the Chu Family's household, but she never told me their location, and I am afraid that I might be late."

"You want to know where the Chu Family is located, is that correct?"

"Yes, if you don't mind telling me."

"It would be my pleasure to help such a polite and handsome young man. Good news is you're going in the right direction. If you continue following this path, you will reach the Chu Family's household four buildings down. So if you see the next building, that would be the first building, and the Chu Family will be on the fourth."

"I understand. Thank you very much, and have a nice day!" Yuan bowed to the old woman before continuing his journey.

"Despite his innocent appearance, he sure has a formidable aura. He must be a powerful cultivator, and he is still so young. The Chu Family is very lucky to have a friend like him." The old woman mumbled to herself as she returned to cleaning her house.

Sometime later, Yuan arrived before a massive gate.

"This should be the Chu Family's household, but I don't see any buildings..." Yuan mumbled to himself.

After pondering for a moment, Yuan decided to jump the gate and follow the only path available.

He normally wouldn't do something like trespassing, but he didn't think the Chu Family deserves any respect for what they are doing to Chu Liuxiang.

After walking for about an hour, Yuan can finally see a building with his divine sense. Although his divine sense is still limited, he was able to see around 500 meters away, and he could keep it active for almost two hours without any rest.

Once he noticed the building, Yuan approached it without any hesitation.

'I am here now... But what should I do now?' Yuan began pondering, as he came to this place without much of a plan.

'Should I just bust the door down and let myself in?' He wondered.

However, he didn't need to spend much time pondering, because after standing in front of the Chu Family's house for less than a minute, someone opened the door and greeted him outside.

A handsome young man walked out of the building and stood a couple of meters away from Yuan.

"Wow, you really came. You're 'Yuan', right?" The handsome young man asked him.

"You were expecting me?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"No, not exactly. We had a feeling that you might come, but we weren't certain. As for my identity, I am Chu Wuyang, Chu Lixuiang's elder brother," said the handsome young man.

And before Yuan could say anything, Chu Wuyang continued, "You're here for my little sister, right?"

"Since you already know, let's not make things difficult."

Chu Wuyang shook his head and said, "Unfortunately, that's not how things work around here. You may be the famous Player Yuan, but your identity has no influence here."

"My parents have already decided that Chu Liuxiang will be marrying into the Qin Family, a rival of ours that we have been fighting for hundreds of years. They figured that it was about time for them to end their hostile relationship with each other with marriage."

"Luckily, the eldest son of the Qin Family has feelings for my little sister, or none of this would've been possible. And if you think my parents are going to give up the chance to befriend the Qin Family that has been a pain in our butt for the last few centuries, then you know nothing about our Chu Family."

Yuan coldly snorted after hearing Chu Wuyang's words, "So what if I don't know the Chu Family? That doesn't matter to me. I didn't come here for the Chu Family. I came here for my friend, Chu Liuxiang."

"I also don't give a damn about what the Chu Family wants. They have no right to decide who Chu Liuxiang spends her life with. Only Chu Liuxiang can make that decision alone."

However, instead of being angry, Chu Wuyang started laughing at Yuan's words.

"You sure bark loud for a nobody. Chu Liuxiang is not even truly part of the Chu Family. She should be grateful for being allowed to live with us. The Chu Family gave her everything when she had nothing. We gave her a

home, a family, servants, treasures— many things that will make most people on earth jealous. However, when the Chu Family asks her for one thing in return, she has the audacity to refuse. Talk about being ungrateful."

Yuan frowned at his words and said, "I have met a lot of unreasonable people, but none of them were like you. You're special— a special type of unreasonable."

"If you 'help' someone with the intention of asking for something in return, are you really helping that person? Sounds like to me you're merely taking advantage of someone who needs help."

This is exactly why he doesn't ask for compensation when he gives away free stuff, and he most certainly does not expect anyone to return the favor, as it was his decision to help them in the first place.

"You know what? I have heard enough of your nonsense. If you're not going to give Chu Liuxiang back, I will take her back myself." Yuan said a moment before releasing some of his aura.

Chu Wuyang did not have much of a reaction and even smiled, "Do you think you're the only Spirit Master in this world?"

"Hah!"

Chu Wuyang released his aura, revealing that he was also a Spirit Master.

Chapter 736 - Are You Really A Spirit Master?

Yuan's expression remained nonchalant even after Chu Wuyang released his cultivation aura.

Although they were both Spirit Masters, Yuan was almost an entire realm above Chu Wuyang, who was only a second level Spirit Master.

Furthermore, with Yuan's godlike talents that allow him to fight those above his own realm, Chu Wuyang was no different than a Spirit Warrior— even a Spirit Apprentice in Yuan's eyes.

"I will give you one last chance to leave this place and forget about Chu Liuxiang. Regardless of your reason, if you cause trouble in our territory, we have the right to kill you! And if you didn't know, allow me to tell you that what you're doing right now has already violated the mountain's rules. You'll be evicted from the mountain the moment we report your intrusion today!"

"Kill me? Unfortunately, I don't think you are capable of doing that, and it's not because you're a reasonable human with morals. As for being evicted from the mountain, who cares, really? Although this place is nice and all, it's only a piece of land. There are countless other places that we can live at. Of course, Chu Liuxiang will also be there with us."

Yuan's words wiped the smile off Chu Wuyang's face really quickly.

"Whether I can kill you or not... Let's put that to the test!"

Chu Wuyang retrieved a dagger that he had hidden underneath his clothes and got into an offensive stance.

"Where's your weapon?" He asked Yuan, who stood there casually.

"I don't need one."

"Hmph! I better not hear any excuses when you lose— that is if you're still alive by then!" Chu Wuyang pounced at Yuan after saying his sentence.

Yuan immediately used his movement technique to dodge Chu Wuyang's strikes, and he was doing so effortlessly.

'What the? I was told that he's blind! There's no way a blind man could move like this, much less dodge my attacks!' Chu Wuyang was someone who took great pride in his fast movement speed, and he hasn't met anyone around his age that could move faster than him.

However, when he looked at Yuan's face, his eyes were definitely closed.

"Is this all you've got? I've fought Spirit Warriors that were stronger than you in Cultivation Online. Are you really a Spirit Master?" Yuan said in a bored voice as he continued dodging Chu Wuyang's strikes.

"Shut the fuck up and fight me properly!" Chu Wuyang shouted at him out of frustration.

"I will... After I decide how I should deal with you." Yuan said.

"You arrogant little fuck—"

Yuan suddenly swung his fist, hitting Chu Wuyang, who was caught off guard, square in the face.

Bang!

Chu Wuyang flew backward until he hit the door to the house, destroying it.

However, he didn't stop at the door and continued flying until he was inside the house, which shocked a few of the servants that were working at the entrance.

"This motherfucker..." Chu Wuyang struggled to get up after being hit, feeling as though he'd been struck in the face by a battering ram, something used to forcefully open doors.

And just as he regained his balance, Yuan appeared before him to give him another punch, knocking him back down to the floor.

Once Chu Wuyang fell onto the floor for the second time, Yuan mounted on top of him and began sending a seemingly endless stream of powerful punches to his face.

"How dare you call yourself her 'brother'?! A brother should protect his sister, not harm her! You're a disgrace!" Yuan shouted at Chu Wuyang in an angry voice as he continued to plummet Chu Wuyang, who could physically feel his own face being flattened, yet his face was so swollen that he was numb to the pain.

"AHHHH! THE YOUNG MASTER! SOMEBODY! HELP!"

The servants there began screaming in a terrified voice as they watched some unknown figure attacking their Young Master.

"Stop!"

A clear voice suddenly resounded right before a leg appeared in front of Yuan, and supporting the leg was a powerful force.

However, Yuan did not even flinch at the incoming leg, and he used one of his hands to catch the leg with seemingly no effort.

"What?!"

Yuan stopped hitting Chu Wuyang and looked at the person who just intervened to see a handsome man standing there with a surprised look on his face.

"Who are you?! And why are you attacking my little brother?!" This handsome man asked Yuan with his leg still raised, as he was unable to free himself from Yuan's grasp.

"So you're his elder brother, huh?" Yuan didn't say anything else and swung his arm like a whip, throwing the handsome man across the room.

After that, he stood up and looked at Chu Wuyang's bloodied face.

"You're lucky. If we were in Cultivation Online, I wouldn't need to worry about killing you by accident."

Yuan no longer bothered with Chu Wuyang, who lost his consciousness shortly after. Instead, he turned his attention to the newcomer.

"Take me to Chu Liuxiang or you will end up like your little brother." Yuan said to him in a cold voice.

"I see... So you're Yuan..." The handsome man said as he stood back up and patted his clothes.

"You're much more terrifying than they give you credit for, Yuan." The handsome man said with a smile.

"However, if you expect me to bow down to you after what you did to my little bro, then you're—"

Before Chu Wuyang's brother could even finish his sentence, Yuan used his movement technique to close their distance.

Yuan then extended his arm out and clutched the elder brother's neck with a claw-like hand.

"I'm not very good at controlling my own strength in this body, especially when I am upset, so you should tell me what I want to know before I accidentally snap your neck." Yuan said to him in a cold voice, and he slowly tightened his grasp on the brother's neck.

"W-Where do you... think you... are?! If you... dare harm... even a single hair... Agh!"

Yuan sighed as he continued to tighten his grasp, "Is everybody in the Chu Family like this? I must say, you guys are very much like Chu Liuxiang in this aspect— your stubbornness, that is."

The brother could feel his windpipe slowly being crushed by Yuan, and he quickly began panicking.

What if Yuan really kills him by accident?

"P-Please... Wait..."

The brother opened his mouth, but just as he was about to speak, another voice resounded.

"Please release him, Young Master Yuan."

Upon hearing this familiar voice, Yuan looked at the tall figure standing not far away from them with his divine sense, and he immediately recognized this person to be Sebastian, Chu Liuxiang's butler.

"That will depend on which side you're on, Sebastian." Yuan said after a moment of silence.

Sebastian released a low sigh before speaking, "I have always been on the Young Lady's side since I was assigned as her butler. I also believe that the Young Lady should be able to decide her own future. However, neither my feelings or beliefs mean a thing, as I am merely a servant for the Chu Family, and my job is to obey their orders. That has been my sole purpose since I was born, not to mention my ancestors that have worked for the Chu Family since ancient times."

Sebastian suddenly changed from a standing position to an aggressive stance, and he continued, "Do you recall our conversation at the Jaded Garden? I know it hasn't been long since then, but I hope you're ready to face the Chu Family."

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Chapter 737 - Fighting Sebastian

"..." Yuan silently stood there even after Sebastian showed his will to fight.

"Do you really intend on fighting me? You're a Spirit Warrior, even weaker than these two. You won't win, and I don't want to hurt you since you're Chu Liuxiang's butler, but that might not be possible if we fight." Yuan said to him.

"I also don't want to fight you, but I have been ordered to keep you away from the Young Lady. If you leave now, we won't need to fight." Sebastian said.

And he continued, "I am also well aware that I cannot beat you, but at least I can say that I'd tried to fulfill my mission."

Yuan shook his head before tossing the individual in his grasp to the end of the room before facing Sebastian.

"Chu Liuxiang... No, Lulu won't be happy if she learns that we'd fought each other. Are you sure you want to continue?" Yuan slowly approached Sebastian.

In response to Yuan's question, Sebastian suddenly rushed forward before launching a fist attack at Yuan.

"Hah!"

Yuan watched as Sebastian's fist slowly approached his face.

Of course, Sebastian's movement was by no means slow, but in Yuan's view, it was barely moving.

Right as Sebastian's fist reached his face, Yuan used one of his hands to block it.

After blocking the attack with ease, Yuan tightened his grasp so that Sebastian couldn't run away.

"I'm sorry..."

Yuan suddenly opened his eyelids, revealing his beautiful eyes and its silver iris.

Sebastian couldn't help but stare at Yuan's colorless eyes with a dazed face.

However, Yuan's eyes suddenly changed colors, turning bright golden.

The next moment, Sebastian suddenly realized that his vision had gone dark, yet his consciousness was clearly still awake.

ROOOOOOOOOOOOOOOAAAAAAAAAARRRR

Sebastian started hearing a subtle yet domineering roar echoing within his head, and this noise gradually grew louder and louder.

Once the noise reached its peak, a massive slit suddenly appeared before Sebastian, almost as though someone had cut the void with a sword.

When this slit in the void opened, it revealed the sharp eye of a beast that reminded Sebastian of reptile eyes, but this eye was countless times bigger than himself, making him feel incredibly insignificant, almost like a mortal before a god.

After seeing this beastly eye, Sebastian began to tremble uncontrollably while an intense sense of fear filled his mind.

Sebastian's real body suddenly went limp after being exposed to Yuan's Dragon's Gaze for only a few seconds.

Yuan closed his eyes when this happened, and he gently laid Sebastian's body onto the floor afterward.

'So I can use Dragon's Gaze even though I am still blind...' Yuan thought to himself as he left the scene after making sure Sebastian was still alive and wasn't harmed too badly by the Dragon's Gaze.

After what happened at the Jaded Garden, Yuan realized that he needed to learn more powerful techniques, so he tried to learn all of the techniques he knew from Cultivation Online.

However, he's already learned most of the weaker techniques from Cultivation Online, leaving him with mostly extremely strong attacks.

The Heavenly Splitting Sword Strike was simply too powerful for him to use in this world, and a single mistake could easily change the landscape. This left him with either Heavenly Domain or Dragon's Gaze, and he ended up trying to learn Dragon's Gaze because he was curious if he could use it despite being blind.

As for the technique Relentless Dragon Overwhelms the Nine Heavens, he couldn't learn it at that time because he still hasn't learned the technique in Cultivation Online, but he already planned on learning it next.

After trying for about two weeks, he'd managed to activate Dragon's Gaze — at least that's what he believed because his eyes had the same burning sensation that he felt whenever he used Dragon's Gaze in Cultivation Online.

However, he couldn't test whether it truly works or not because he didn't want to use Dragon's Gaze on Meixiu or the others, so he waited for the perfect moment to test out the Dragon's Gaze, and he found that moment with Sebastian, who he didn't want to physically harm, so he could only try using Dragon's Gaze on him to take him out of the fight mentally.

Yuan wandered the Chu Family's residence for the next couple of minutes until he ran into someone, as he had no idea where to go in such a massive place.

He eventually encountered a young maid, who was quietly dusting furniture in the hallway while humming to herself in a cheerful manner, seemingly in

her own world and unaware of the chaos.

"Excuse me, do you know where I can find Chu Liuxiang?" Yuan asked her.

"Hm? Are you perhaps Young Master Qin? I thought your visit was scheduled for next week." The young maid mistook Yuan as someone from the Qin Family.

"Uh... The schedule changed." Yuan decided to play along with her.

"Is that so... Anyways, you should be able to find the Young Lady in her garden," she then said.

"The garden?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"Oh, I'm sorry. This is your first time here, right? Please, follow me. I will take you there."

"Thank you." Yuan nodded and began following this young maid.

Meanwhile, inside the garden, Chu Liuxiang sat before the pond that was beside her immortal cave with a dispirited expression on her face.

"Yuan... He should be coming soon to take me away from this place just like he'd promised, right? I only hope that nobody gets hurt over this..." She sighed.

She turned to look at the beautiful woman that was silently cultivating on top of her immortal cave.

"Master, did my parents ask you to babysit me?"

Senior Qi responded without opening her eyes, "No, I am here to deal with your little lover because your parents are expecting his presence soon."

"What?! You're going to fight Yuan?! You can't do that, Master!" Chu Liuxiang exclaimed.

"Why not?" Senior Qi asked in a calm voice.

"I-It's for your own good..." Chu Liuxiang responded in a low voice.

Senior Qi finally opened her eyes, and she turned to look at Chu Liuxiang with a narrowed gaze.

"You think I won't be able to defeat him?" She asked in a cold voice.

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Chapter 738 - Chu Liuxiang's Master

"It hasn't even been a year since I stopped beating you and you have already forgotten what I am capable of? Want me to remind you?" Senior Qi said as she stared daggers at Chu Liuxiang.

"That's not it, Master. I am well aware of your capabilities, but compared to Yuan... I don't want to call him a monster, but... If you have seen what he's capable of, you'll understand my feelings."

"Hmph! As if I'd lose to some 18-year-old who only recently regained his ability to move!" Senior Qi coldly snorted.

"But Master, you're not that much older than him yourself... And Yuan, he defeated a demon by himself." Chu Liuxiang said with a bittersweet smile.

"Wait... What did you just say?" Senior Qi's face suddenly became serious.

"Y-You're only 25 years old, which isn't that much older than Yuan. Or am I wrong?" Chu Liuxiang swallowed nervously when she saw how Senior Qi's expression changed, and she wondered if it was because she had mentioned her age.

"Not that! You said that he'd defeated a demon by himself? I thought he merely assisted the Six Spiritual Families? That's what they said." Senior Qi said.

In order to keep Yuan away from the spotlight, the Six Spiritual Families told the world that Yuan had only assisted them in defeating the demon. In

truth, Yuan had defeated the demon by himself, but only very few individuals are aware of this fact.

"Oh, right. The Six Spiritual Families changed the story a bit to help Yuan since they knew he didn't like to be in the spotlight. But it's true. Yuan fought the demon from beginning to end by himself without any help." Chu Liuxiang revealed the truth.

"...Are you okay, Master?"

Chu Liuxiang asked her when she noticed that Senior Qi looked a little nervous afterward.

"I am..."

Just as Senior Qi opened her mouth, a loud voice suddenly resounded.

"Lulu! Are you here?! I am here to take you back as promised!" Yuan's voice echoed in the garden.

"Yuan?!"

Chu Liuxiang immediately stood up and looked around with an excited expression on her face.

"Yuan! I am here!" She shouted back.

And hearing Chu Liuxiang's voice respond, Yuan immediately rushed in the direction her voice came from.

"Huh? Yuan? He's not Young Master Qin?" The young maid stood there with a dazed look on her face when she realized that she'd screwed up.

After standing there for a few moments, she turned around and ran away from the scene while silently praying to herself, hoping that nobody saw her together with Yuan.

A few minutes later, Yuan arrived at the pond and the immortal cave to see Chu Liuxiang standing behind a beautiful young woman.

"Lulu! Are you okay? Are you hurt?" Yuan immediately asked her.

Chu Liuxiang vigorously shook her head out of excitement, "No, I am okay. What about you? Are you hurt? What happened to my family?"

"Well... I encountered your brother Chu Wuyang as well as his elder brother... And Sebastian..."

"My brothers and Sebastian? Did something happen to them?" Chu Liuxiang could sense Yuan's nervousness even though they were standing so far away from each other.

"They stood in my way, so I took them down." Yuan sighed.

"T-Took them down? You killed them?" Chu Liuxiang's eyes widened with shock.

"Eh? N-No! I merely knocked them unconscious!" Yuan said, skipping some details, such as turning Chu Wuyang's face into a bloody mess and nearly breaking the elder brother's neck.

"I see... As long as Sebastian is alive, I won't complain. He might have tried to stop you, but it's not because he wanted to. I hope you'll forgive him. I don't care about the other two. They have always been a pain to deal with. I couldn't care less even if they died." Chu Liuxiang said.

"I know. Sebastian is only doing his job." Yuan nodded.

"Ahem! Are you ignoring me on purpose?" Senior Qi suddenly cleared her throat, interrupting their 'reunion'.

"Who are you?" Yuan quickly asked.

"My surname is Qi. Do you recognize it?" Senior Qi suddenly asked him, almost as though she was expecting him to recognize her surname for some reason.

"No, I don't. Should I?" Yuan said.

"..."

Senior Qi turned silent for a moment.

"I heard from my disciple that you had defeated the demon from the Jaded Garden all by yourself. Is that true?" She asked him a moment later.

"Disciple? So you're Lulu's master?" Yuan was surprised to hear this.

"Answer my question! Did you defeat the demon by yourself?!" Senior Qi asked again, clearly anxious for an answer.

"So what if I did?"

"How did you do it?"

"Huh? Why do you care?" Yuan found this Senior Qi's behavior to be very suspicious.

"Because I don't believe you. There's no way a nobody like you can defeat a demon! After all, they're indestructible! They are supreme beings that can only be sealed!" Senior Qi exclaimed.

"You..." Yuan was surprised by Senior Qi's knowledge regarding demons. It was almost as though she knew of their existence even before the incident at the Jaded Garden.

"You... Who are you? Why do you know so much about demons?" It was now Yuan's turn to ask such questions.

"..."

Senior Qi did not respond to his question. Instead, she lifted her hand and pointed her palm towards the immortal cave.

The next moment, a sword flew out of the immortal cave and into her hands.

'Qi Manipulation? She's a Spirit Grandmaster?' Yuan was inwardly shocked when Senior Qi used Qi Manipulation.

"If you defeat me, I will tell you what you want to know. But if I defeat you, you'll tell me everything you know," she said to him while pointing the sword at him in a provocative manner.

"Very well..." Yuan nodded in agreement.

"Where's your weapon? I don't want to hear any excuses when you lose." Senior Qi then asked.

Yuan didn't say anything and raised his arm until it was parallel to the ground.

Senior Qi and Chu Liuxiang watched his movements with interest.

A large sword that was as tall as Yuan himself suddenly appeared out of thin air the next moment and entered his grasp.

The second Yuan tightened his grasp on the sword, his aura skyrocketed, and the sword began vibrating with excitement.

"T-That's his sword in Cultivation Online... How did he..." Chu Liuxiang mumbled in a dazed voice when she recognized Yuan's sword—the Empyrean Overlord!

Chapter 739 - Sealed

"Get back, Liuxiang. You'll get in the way." Senior Qi said to Chu Liuxiang, who quickly retreated to the immortal cave.

"Are you ready?" She asked Yuan.

"Whenever you are." He nodded.

And without saying another word, Senior Qi rushed towards him, closing their distance almost immediately.

"Hah!"

Senior Qi swung her sword without using any techniques, only relying on her strength and powerful spiritual energy.

Clang!

However, Yuan blocked her attack with ease, and he only had one arm on the sword.

Senior Qi raised one of her eyebrows in surprise before swinging her sword again with even more strength.

Yuan was pushed back a little this time, but he still only needed one arm to defend against the attack.

"At least you're much stronger than the Chu brothers." Yuan said with a smile on his face.

"Don't get cocky! The fight is just beginning!"

The two of them began exchanging blows back and forth for the next few minutes.

"Let's see how you'll deal with this!"

Sometime later, Senior Qi distanced herself from Yuan, and once she was at a safe distance, she began making symbols with her hand.

"!!!"

The way Senior Qi moved her hands resembled how Array Masters create arrays, and Yuan wondered if she was going to use arrays.

"Seal!"

Senior Qi suddenly shouted.

"What the?"

Yuan blurted out when his body suddenly stopped moving.

'I cannot move? No... It feels more like I am being restricted by invisible chains... What kind of technique is this?' Yuan wondered to himself, even admiring the technique a little.

"How do you like my family's secret technique? It's not really effective on humans since it was never meant to be used on them, but this much strength is more than enough to restrict anyone, even a talented Spirit Master like you."

"Y-Yuan! Your legs! They're turning into stone!" Chu Liuxiang's voice suddenly resounded, and it was filled with distress.

"What?" Yuan looked at his legs after hearing Chu Liuxiang's words, and sure enough, his legs had turned into stone!

"This technique..." Yuan was baffled when he saw the petrifying effects, as it was almost the same as his demon sealing techniques.

"You... You know demon sealing techniques?" Wanting to confirm his suspicions, he decided to ask her.

"You want me to answer your questions? You'll have to defeat me. However, it doesn't appear that you have defeated me, so I won't tell you anything." Senior Qi said with a smirk on her face.

Clearly, she wanted to get back at him for refusing to answer her questions before.

"Don't think you have already won just because I cannot move. Despite my situation, I can still defeat you whenever I want." Yuan said to her.

"Is that so?" Senior Qi casually walked up to his face and said, "And how are you going to do that when half of your body has turned into stone?"

By now, the petrifying effect had spread all the way to his chest.

"If you don't hurry up and surrender, your entire body will turn into stone, and when that happens, even I cannot revert the damages. That means you'll turn into a stone statue forever."

"What?! That's dangerous, Master! Hurry up and release him!" Chu Liuxiang exclaimed after hearing Senior Qi's words.

However, Yuan remained calm and said, "I will win this fight."

"I don't know where you're getting your confidence, but do you even understand your situation right now? You cannot even lift a finger, much less defeat me."

In response to her words, Yuan merely stood there with a calm smile on his face, allowing the petrifying effect to slowly consume his body— not that he could move his body.

When the effect reached his neck, Senior Qi frowned and said to him, "Do you really intend on dying in such a manner? Is your pride really so valuable that you'd give your life away for it? Being sealed is a fate that's worse than death, you know? Even after your body has completely turned

into stone, your body won't immediately die, which means that you'll still be alive until you die of natural causes."

"When you're sealed, you won't feel hunger or thirst, and your internal organs will be supported by the spiritual energy your body naturally gathers, allowing you to live for many months, even years without any problems."

"Do you really want to spend the rest of your life in such a miserable state? Hurry up and surrender." Senior Qi tried to convince him to give up.

However, Yuan remained silent.

"If you think I am going to free you at the last second so that I won't kill you, then you're overestimating me. I will really let your entire body turn into stone. Don't test me." Senior Qi added.

"Don't worry, I don't have such thoughts." Yuan said, still with a calm smile on his face.

"Yuan! What are you doing?! What am I going to do if you're sealed forever?! Life isn't worth living if you're not here with me!" Chu Liuxiang shouted at him with tears flowing down her face.

"Believe me, Lulu. I won't lose. I promise you that I will defeat her and take you back to the family with me." Yuan said.

"You better!"

A few more moments later, Yuan's entire body became stone, turning into a stone statue and looking exactly like the sealed demon in the Jaded Garden.

However, even after being sealed, Yuan still had a smile on his face.

"This crazy bastard... He really allowed himself to become sealed. I have never met a madman like him before..." Senior Qi stared at Yuan's stone face with a dazed expression on her face.

"Master, if anything happens to him, I will never forgive you!" Chu Liuxiang said to her with a deep frown.

Senior Qi looked at her and sighed, "Calm down. I can make him normal again even though he's fully sealed. I only said that I couldn't just to scare him. In fact, since this technique isn't meant for humans, he will automatically break out of that state in a few days. However, since he dared to defy me, I am going to let him suffer for a few days."

"R-Really?" Chu Liuxiang mumbled with a dumbfounded look on her face.

"You really think I am that cruel of a person? I—"

"Not that, Master. I meant the 'few days' part. It's only been a few moments and there are already cracks on him." Chu Liuxiang pointed at Yuan.

"What? That's impossible!"

Senior Qi frowned before turning to look at Yuan.

"I-Impossible..."

Senior Qi muttered in a shocked voice when she saw that Yuan's seal was really weakening with cracks already.

However, she couldn't comprehend how that was possible.

'Even if he's a Spirit Master, he shouldn't be able to break out of my seal this quickly. The only way this is possible is if he knows how the technique works... Did he really defeat the demon by himself? But that's even more absurd!'

The stone on Yuan's face suddenly began falling off, revealing his soft skin once again.

"When I first encountered the demon at the Jaded Garden, I wondered if there would be any families in this world that could deal with them like the Demon Sealing Clan inside Cultivation Online."

"Since you can also use demon sealing techniques, I can only assume that you guys actually exist.. Or am I wrong?" Yuan turned to look at Senior Qi, who stood there with a baffled face.

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Chapter 740 - Qi Family

Chapter 740 Qi Family

"Who are you, really? If you belong to one of us, I should recognize you. However, I don't know you." Senior Qi narrowed her eyes on him.

"I'm afraid that I cannot answer your question since you haven't defeated me yet." Yuan suddenly pointed his sword at Senior Qi before mumbling in a low voice.

"Seal."

"What?!"

Senior Qi's eyes widened with shock when she suddenly lost control over her body's movements.

'I-Impossible! He also knows our technique?!'

Not only did Yuan know her technique, it also appeared to be much stronger than her own judging by how much quicker the petrifying effect was affecting her body.

In just a few seconds, half of Senior Qi's body had turned into stone.

However, Senior Qi wasn't panicking.

She even showed a confident smile and said, "I'm surprised. To think you knew so much about demon sealing clans and even our techniques. However, you should know that demon sealing techniques do not have any effect on humans. Even if I don't do anything, I will be able to break free from the seal after a few days. If I try, I can break out of it within seconds just like you did."

"Then let's make a bet. I will give you ten minutes to break out of the seal. If you cannot do it, then it's my victory, and you will have to admit defeat." Yuan suddenly suggested.

"Ten minutes? Hahaha! I only need one minute to break your seal!" Senior Qi laughed out loud.

"I will see you in a minute." Senior Qi glared at Yuan until her entire body turned into stone.

Chu Liuxiang approached Yuan and asked, "Do you think she will break out of the seal in a minute? You managed to break out of her seal in just a few seconds, after all."

"Who knows." Yuan shrugged.

"Eh? You don't know? Then why did you make a bet with her, even giving her ten whole minutes? That's not something you do if you're not confident in your own abilities." Chu Liuxiang stared at him with a slightly dumbfounded face.

"I am confident, but that doesn't really mean anything."

"Let's just wait and see then." Chu Liuxiang said, and they proceeded to wait for Senior Qi to break the seal.

One minute later.

"She's late. It's been longer than a minute. Does this mean you win?" Chu Liuxiang said.

"I guess so, but let's give her the full ten minutes."

Chu Liuxiang nodded, and they continued to wait.

Ten minutes later.

"I really hope she's still alive..." Chu Liuxiang said in a low voice.

"She's definitely still alive. I can sense her spiritual energy, and she is still trying to break through the seal even as we speak." Yuan said.

"What now? Are you going to release the seal?"

To Chu Liuxiang's surprise, Yuan shook his head, "No, I will let her suffer a little more. This is what she gets for being so arrogant, and she also wanted to stop me from taking you home."

"Master does have the tendency to act arrogantly from time to time, but she's not a bad person. She taught me many things ever since I came to the Chu Family. I even think of her as an elder sister."

"Alright, I will reduce a few hours from her punishment." Yuan said with a smile.

Chu Liuxiang also chuckled.

"Chu Liuxiang!"

A cold voice suddenly resounded behind them.

When Chu Liuxiang turned around, she could see her parents standing in the distance with many of their guards following behind them.

"Stay behind me." Yuan said as he stood in between her and the Chu Family.

"Where is Senior Qi?! I asked her to deal with that bastard!" Chu Shijian shouted in an angry voice.

"Dear! Look behind them!" Chu Shufen pointed at the stone statue behind Yuan and Chu Liuxiang.

"Y-You bastard! What have you done to her?! Do you have any idea who she is?! If you harmed even a single hair on her body, you're a dead man!" Chu Shijian roared in a deafening tone.

"I don't know her, but as you can see for yourself, it's a little too late for that kind of talk. However, you can't blame me. You can only blame yourself—your Chu Family for making me come here." Yuan said with a cold expression on his face.

"It's over... You have no idea what you've just done! The Qi Family will kill all of us once they learn that she had died while within our territory!" Chu Shijian mumbled in a fearful voice.

The Chu Family is one of the biggest families in the world, but that doesn't mean they are fearless. The Qi Family is a secret powerhouse that has lived in seclusion for even longer than the Six Spiritual Families, and they are one of very few powers that can make the Chu Family tremble in fear.

Yuan raised his eyebrows. Is the Qi Family really that powerful?

'I guess it makes sense for them to be so powerful since they have to fight demons and all...' Yuan thought to himself.

"The relationship between our families was reaching its peak! They even sent over the most talented genius in their family to our family as a sign of their trust, but you had to ruin everything!" Chu Shijian's eyes were bloodshot as of this moment.

"I didn't plan on killing you even after learning about what you have done to my two sons, but I must avenge Senior Qi by taking your life. Hopefully, the Qi Family won't kill all of us with your sacrifice."

Chu Shijian pointed at Yuan and shouted, "Bring me his head!"

The guards behind him immediately rushed forward and surrounded Yuan and Chu Liuxiang.

"F-Father! Please wait! There is something—"

"Shut up! If you don't want to die with him, get away from him!" Chu Shijian shouted.

"Senior Qi came here and took you in as her disciple, yet you allowed her to be killed just like that?! Even if I don't punish you later, the Qi Family will definitely do so!"

"It's alright, Lulu. Stand back. I will handle this." Yuan said to her with a smile.

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Chapter 741 - Fighting The Chu Family

"B-But this is all just a misunderstanding! If we let my father know that Senior Qi is actually..."

"No, don't tell him. I have been wondering how I should deal with your parents. This shall be their punishment." Yuan said.

Chu Liuxiang looked at him with wide eyes, but she couldn't refute him for some reason.

"Okay... Try not to get hurt." Chu Liuxiang said to him before leaving his side.

The guards there allowed Chu Liuxiang to leave their encirclement without any trouble.

Yuan scanned the guards there with his divine sense.

'Mostly Spirit Warriors with only two Spirit Masters, huh... I don't need my weapon for this.'

Not wanting to accidentally kill these people, Yuan stowed the Emptyrean Overlord.

"This bastard is underestimating us..."

The guards there were provoked by Yuan's action even though that wasn't his intention.

"Get him! There's no need to hold back since the Patriarch has asked for his head!"

The guards began rushing at Yuan the next moment.

Seeing this, Yuan used his movement technique to maneuver around them, and because there were so many of them, it actually gave Yuan an advantage, allowing him to confuse them easier.

"W-Where did he go?!"

"He's right behind you!"

"No, he's over here!"

"Hey—"

"What the—?!"

"How is he moving this fast?! He's not human!"

The guards were shocked when they realized that they couldn't even follow his movements, much less touch him.

"Ah!"

"Gak!"

"Fuc—!"

Yuan began knocking out these guards one by one, rendering over half of the guards unconscious in mere minutes.

Sometime later, after defeating all of the guards, Yuan turned to face Chu Shijian, who was trembling with anger.

"Are you going to try and kill me next?" Yuan asked him in a calm voice.

Chu Shijian gritted his teeth.

If someone like Senior Qi lost to Yuan, there was no way for him to defeat Yuan.

Chu Shufen suddenly tapped his shoulders and said, "Let's get him together."

"Alright. Watch my back." Chu Shijian nodded.

Once they were prepared, Chu Shijian and his wife began their attack on Yuan.

"Taste my Force of Hell!"

Chu Shijian's fists suddenly became engulfed in red flames as they flew toward Yuan's face.

'What a powerful technique!'

Yuan thought to himself as he used his movement technique to dodge the attack.

Boom!

Chu Shijian's fist exploded with fire right after Yuan dodged it.

However, right as Yuan dodged the attack, he noticed that Chu Shufen was already behind him, almost as though she had predicted his movements.

Chu Shufen was also in a kicking motion, and before Yuan could react, he was sent flying by Chu Shufen's powerful kick.

"Yuan!"

Chu Liuxiang immediately grew nervous.

"I'm fine. I didn't expect her to read my movement technique." Yuan said as he stood back up without any injuries.

"How the hell is he still standing after eating my kick like that? That kick had enough force to shatter boulders and bend thick steel! Even if it couldn't kill him, it should've rendered him immobilized, yet he stood up so casually!" Chu Shufen appeared to be even more surprised than Yuan from that exchange.

"If one isn't enough to take him down, give him a few more! Let's do it!" Chu Shijian said, and they went for another attack.

While Chu Shijian rushed forward, Chu Shufen stayed behind to watch Yuan so that she could read his movement again.

However, Yuan directly ignored Chu Shijian this time and went straight for Chu Shufen after avoiding him.

"If you think I am vulnerable, then you've just made a poor judgement!" Chu Shufen didn't even try to run away and decided to face Yuan head-on.

Chu Shufen's aura suddenly skyrocketed right before she threw a punch at Yuan.

However, Yuan wasn't even close enough to be hit by her fist.

Despite that, Yuan suddenly stopped running at her and dodged to the side.

Whoosh!

An invisible force flew right past Yuan after he dodged.

'Qi Manipulation?' Yuan frowned when he saw how similar it felt to Qi Manipulation.

'No, Lulu also did the same thing before. If I recall correctly, it's called Spiritual Control...'

"How dare you ignore me!"

Chu Shijian suddenly appeared behind Yuan while he stopped for a moment to ponder.

"Your head is mine!"

Chu Shijian had a hidden dagger in his grasp as he went for Yuan's neck.

"As if I'd fall for the same trick twice!"

Yuan saw Chu Shijian coming from a mile away because of his divine sense, and he used his movement technique to dodge the strike.

"Che! What a fucking annoying movement technique!" Chu Shijian cursed out loud after failing for the second time to kill Yuan.

"So you're seriously trying to kill me, huh?" Yuan sighed out loud.

If he didn't dodge the attack just now, Chu Shijian would've definitely taken his head.

As for Chu Shufen, her attack would've also killed him if his body wasn't so strong.

"Since you're trying to kill me, don't blame me for doing the same."

Yuan suddenly opened his eyes and activated Dragon's Gaze, stunning both Chu Shijian and Chu Shufen at the same time.

And while they were stunned, he slowly approached them.

Since they were no longer capable of fighting, Yuan could do as he pleased with them.

"Are you really going to kill them?" Chu Liuxiang asked him with a nervous look on her face.

"Do you want me to?" Yuan asked her in return.

"Of course not. Although they may have wronged me this time, it is also true that they have cared for me for the last decade. And I don't want to see you killing people... At least not in the real world." Chu Liuxiang sighed.

Yuan smiled, "Don't worry, I never planned on killing them. I gain nothing by becoming a murderer."

"Then what are you going to do to them?"

"Although I won't kill them, I won't forgive them so easily either.." Yuan said as he continued to approach Chu Shijian, who was kneeling on the ground with a soulless look on his face.

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Chapter 742 - Punishment

Once Yuan was standing in front of Chu Shijian, he took a deep breath before speaking in a slow but clear voice, "Despite all the things you have done— despite my urges, I won't kill you. However, it is a fact that you tried to kill me today, and to make sure that you won't attack me again in the future, I will end your life... as a Cultivator."

Chu Shijian snapped out of his daze when he heard Yuan's words, but before he could open his mouth and utter a single word, Yuan swung his arm and punched Chu Shijian square in the stomach, shattering his Dantian.

Cough!

Chu Shijian coughed up a mouthful of blood afterward.

"Ahh... Ahh... No... Not my cultivation!" A horrified look appeared on Chu Shijian's face when he could feel his spiritual energy leaving his Dantian before leaving from the pores on his body.

"What... What have you done?!" Chu Shijian snapped at Yuan with a furious face.

"How dare you cripple my cultivation! Do you have any idea how much time, effort, and money I have sacrificed to reach that point?! Without my cultivation, the Chu Family will be doomed! And this is all your fault!"

"You were prepared to take my life, so I took away your cultivation in return. It's a fair trade if you ask me. At least you get to keep your life." Yuan said.

"Don't fuck with me! I'd rather you kill me now than live the life of a mortal!"

Yuan shook his head and said, "If you want to die, that's your decision. I already made my decision."

Tears began flowing from Chu Shijian's face.

Chu Liuxiang swallowed nervously when she saw this scene, as this is her first time seeing Chu Shijian shed such sorrowful tears.

Yuan ignored Chu Shijian and turned his focus to Chu Shufen next.

When Chu Shijian realized what Yuan was about to do, he stood up and shouted, "Y-You bastard! You're not satisfied with ruining my life so you're going to ruin my wife's life as well?!"

Hearing his words, Yuan calmly responded, "It wouldn't be fair if I only took your cultivation and not hers. Furthermore, she also tried to kill me. It only makes sense for me to take her cultivation as well."

"I swear to god, if you dare hurt even a single hair on her body, I will do whatever it takes to make your life miserable before taking your life! You might think that you have defeated the Chu Family because you took away my cultivation, but we still have many resources at our disposal, and it will all be used to dispose of you!"

"..."

The place turned dead silent for a good moment until Chu Liuxiang spoke.

"Yuan, I think you have already punished them enough. Although I wouldn't mind fighting the entire world with you, I cannot say the same about the others. Think about Meixiu and the others that will be dragged into this mess if you continue."

"Father, I will leave the Chu Family after today. I wish that I could've left the family in a better manner, but what's done is already done. And despite what happened between us, I don't hate you or the Chu Family. In fact, I am feeling grateful to you and the family. After all, you gave me a chance to

experience what it feels like to have a family even if it is not an ordinary family."

"Now that I am old enough to have my own family, I am going to start one with the person I love— Yuan."

After a moment of silence, Chu Liuxiang looked at Senior Qi, who was still sealed, and said, "As for Master— Senior Qi is still alive. You can ask her to explain everything to you once she breaks out of that seal in a few days."

Chu Liuxiang suddenly went to Yuan and grabbed his hand before mumbling to him, "Let's go home now, shall we? I don't want us to miss Meixiu's breakfast."

Hearing her words, Yuan could only nod his head.

"Okay."

Chu Liuxiang and Yuan left the scene shortly after, leaving the Chu Family in havoc.

"Are you okay?" Chu Liuxiang asked Yuan as they walked home together.

"Yes, I am not hurt."

"I am not talking about your body, you silly. You did some incredible things today— things that I didn't know you were capable of. If you want to talk about it, I will always be here to listen."

"I guess I was acting a little different today. I don't know why, but I felt incredibly angry today, yet it wasn't the type of anger that I am used to. Maybe I had released some of my built-up anger for my own family on the Chu Family."

And he continued, "But it's okay. I will be fine since everything has ended now."

However, Chu Liuxiang shook her head with a bitter smile, and she sighed, "Unfortunately, things are not over yet, as much as I want it to be."

"Huh? What do you mean? Do you think the Chu Family will take revenge in the future?" Yuan asked her.

"Yes, but I am not talking about my parents— about Chu Shijian and Chu Shufen. I don't know if I told you this before or not, but my father has multiple wives, and they all control a small portion of the Chu Family in other places. The Chu Family is simply too big for my father to manage alone, so he made his other wives assist him in managing the family."

"Although we didn't see any of them today beside my father's main wife, things would've played out very differently if they were there. With that being said, there's a good chance that they'll retaliate because of what you did today."

"Also..."

"There's more?" Yuan was speechless.

"Of course. Have you forgotten about the Dragon Spiral Mountain? We should start looking for a new place to stay when we get back because we will most likely be evicted for our actions today."

"Aiya..." Yuan sighed out loud.

"Even though I don't mind moving, it kind of hurts that we have to move so soon after moving to this place, not to mention the amount of money we had spent to live here. I will have to apologize to the others once we get back. They also paid for the house, after all."

"I'm sure they'll understand.." Chu Liuxiang smiled.

Chapter 743 - Preparing To Move Again

By the time Yuan and Chu Liuxiang returned home, everyone except Meixiu was already seated at the dining table.

"Huh? Yuan? Where have you been? Meixiu went to look for you in your room just now." Wang Ming said to him when they returned.

"Sorry, I had some business at the Chu Family." Yuan said to them.

"I'll go find Meixiu. You guys can eat first."

Yuan and Chu Liuxiang went back to his room to find Meixiu knocking on their door.

"There's no need to knock. We're here." Yuan said to her.

"Huh?" Meixiu turned around to see them standing behind her, and Yuan looked a little messy, almost as though he'd been in a fight recently.

"What happened to you?" She asked.

"I went to the Chu Family to bring her back." Yuan pointed at Chu Liuxiang, who had a bashful smile on her face.

"It's a little embarrassing, but I had some trouble at home, and Yuan came to save me," she said.

"Well... Breakfast is prepared..." Meixiu didn't know what else to say.

Yuan nodded, "I will tell you guys about it at the dining table. Let me change my clothes first."

"Me too."

"Okay."

While Meixiu returned to the others, Yuan and Chu Liuxiang changed their clothes before making their way back to the dining room.

Everybody there could tell that something was on Yuan's mind when they saw his expression, but nobody said a word until after breakfast was finished.

"If you have something to say, say it already." Li Jinxi was the first to speak out.

Yuan sighed before nodding his head, "Alright. This might be a lot, but it's important. Today, I went to the Chu Family and kind of fought them."

"You what?!" Wang Ming exclaimed.

"They were going to take Lulu away from us and force her to marry some family she doesn't want to be with, so I went there to take her back by force. I fought her parents and crippled her father's cultivation before bringing her back, and because of my actions, there's a good chance that we're going to get evicted from the mountain soon..."

The entire place turned dead silent as everyone in the room stared at him with gawking faces.

"W-W-Wait... Why don't you start from the beginning and slow down?" Shi Lang said.

Yuan nodded and recalled the whole incident from the beginning.

Of course, everyone there was shocked by what they heard. None of them could've expected Yuan to invade the Chu Family by himself while they were all sleeping.

"Yuan... Although I am confident in your abilities, nor am I upset that we might be evicted, you should've at least told us that you were going to raid one of the biggest cultivation families in this world." Wang Ming rubbed his temples.

"The Chu Family and the Six Spiritual Families have always been on bad terms since forever. They like to live in the spotlight while we prefer living in the shadows. I was really surprised when I found out that Miss Chu was actually from the Chu Family. However, now that we belong to the same faction, we have a responsibility to protect each other, so I would've helped you fight the Chu Family if you asked."

"I have to agree with Wang Ming on this one, Yuan. You should've at least told us before doing something so dangerous by yourself." Meixiu sighed.

"I know, but I didn't want to worry you guys."

"That's not good enough, Yuan. As fellow members of the same faction, we need to share the burden together. That's what separates the good factions from the ordinary ones." Wang Ming said.

"Although it's already in the past, you need to tell us in advance if you do something crazy again in the future." Wang Bingbing said.

"Alright, I will let you all know next time."

"Good. Now what? Should we begin packing since we're going to be moving soon?" Wang Ming asked a moment later.

"I mean... We don't know if we're really going to be evicted or not..." Shi Lang said.

"Are you kidding me? Yuan invaded the Chu Family that lives in the upper levels of the mountain! He violated many rules today, it would be a miracle if we don't get kicked out of the mountain! Hell, I am expecting a very expensive compensation fee as well!"

"Wang Ming's right. I violated multiple rules today. The Manager will probably visit us by the end of the day to kick us out. Let's pack our stuff and prepare to move out." Yuan said.

"As for our next home... We'll figure that out afterward. Once again, I am sorry for the trouble. I know we have spent a lot of money to buy this place, so I am going to pay you all back."

"Nah, you don't have to worry about it. The money was our parents' anyway. Also, it's not like we disapprove of your actions today. We would've even supported you if we knew about it earlier." Wang Ming said.

"Let's not forget about the Heaven-rank techniques we received from you. Those are already worth more than this place." Shi Lang smiled.

"What Heaven-rank techniques?" Wu Zao asked, as he wasn't at the Myriad of Techniques with them.

"We all got a Heaven-rank technique from Yuan when we ascended." Wang Ming said.

"What! You should've told me! I would've ascended sooner if that was the case!" Wu Zao exclaimed.

"Yuan! I am going to ascend right after we find a new home!"

"Me too!" Xi Murong said.

"Okay." Yuan nodded.

Everybody returned to their own rooms shortly after and began packing their luggage.

"Y-Yuan! She's here! The Manager!" Wang Ming went to alert him of the Manager's presence.

"Let's go." Yuan quickly followed Wang Ming to the front of the house.

Yuan swallowed nervously when he saw the cold expression on the Manager's beautiful face.

"G-Good evening, Manager..." Yuan greeted her with a stiff smile.

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Chapter 744 - Did You Or Did You Not?

"Let's sit down before we have our conversation." The Manager ignored his greetings and spoke in a cold voice.

Yuan sighed inwardly. He expected this would happen, and he didn't blame the Manager for being mad at him for the mess he'd caused.

Yuan led the Manager to another room shortly after.

However, when the others tried to enter the room with them, the Manager stopped them and said, "I only need to speak with him."

"..."

"Can you guys wait for me outside?" Yuan said to them with a bittersweet smile.

"G-Good luck..." Wang Ming said to him before leaving them alone.

Wang Ming then went to notify the other members of the Manager's arrival.

"She's really here, huh? Do you think she's going to evict us?"

"Who knows. Maybe Yuan will be able to persuade her somehow."

"Let's play a game and guess the result."

While the others played their guessing game, Yuan sat in front of the Manager with a nervous look on his face.

He didn't feel this nervous even when facing the Chu Family, but before this Manager, he was completely different.

"I will be asking you a few questions now. You will answer them with either 'did' or 'did not'. I don't want to hear anything else— not even your explanation. Do you understand?"

"I understand."

The Manager retrieved a long piece of paper and proceeded to ask, "Did you or did you not enter the Chu Family's territory without permission today?"

"I did..."

"Did you or did you not force your way into their residence today?"

"I did..."

"Did you or did you not beat up Chu Wuyang today?"

"I did..."

"Did you or did you not..."

The Manager continued to confirm everything that he's done today.

"Did you or did you not cripple Chu Shijian's cultivation today?"

"I did..."

Yuan could only repeat these two words for the past few minutes, as there was not a single thing that he 'did not' do.

Once the questioning ended, the Manager neatly folded her paper and proceeded to stare at him with a cold gaze.

"How long has it been since you moved into the mountain?" She asked him.

"A few weeks now, I guess."

"So in just a few weeks, you have managed to break almost every rule in the mountain, and it was all done in the same day. This is an unprecedented case. I have never seen someone cause so much trouble in a single day, nor have I seen anyone cause as much trouble as you in the Dragon Spiral Mountain."

"Sorry... But are you not going to ask me why I did what I did?" Yuan asked her.

"I don't care about that. Regardless of who's right or wrong, if you have any problems with another resident in the Dragon Spiral Mountain, you contact me."

"Now, what do you think I should do with you?"

"Since I broke the rules... I won't complain even if you decide to evict us." Yuan said with a resolved face, almost as though he'd accepted his fate.

"Indeed, you would be evicted under normal circumstances." The Manager quickly said.

"Under normal circumstances?" Yuan raised his eyebrows at her odd choice of words.

"Is this not a normal circumstance?"

The Manager narrowed her eyes and said, "First of all, I would evict you without hesitation if I could. Second, I am only a Manager. Lastly, the one who makes the final decisions is the Lord of the mountain."

"So the Lord has decided not to evict us?" Yuan couldn't help but feel a little hopeful for his situation.

"That is not entirely correct. The Lord has decided to not evict you guys, but it is only temporary. He has a request for you— and your faction. If you help him with this request, he will not only allow you to continue living on his mountain, he will even forgive you for today."

"Really? That's great! What does he need from us?"

"I don't know. You'll have to speak with him yourself and find out," she said.

"Speak with him? So I get to meet with the Lord?" Yuan did not expect this development at all.

"Yes, I will meet you in the front tomorrow morning after sunrise. Don't be late, or I will evict you guys even if I get punished by the Lord."

"I won't be late! I promise!" Yuan exclaimed.

"Then I will see you tomorrow."

The Manager stood up and left the place shortly after without saying anything else.

"What happened? Are we evicted?" Wang Ming and the others asked him after she left.

"No, we're not evicted yet—"

"Yes! I won this bet!" Shi Lang exclaimed before Yuan could even finish his sentence.

"Really? We're not evicted? Even though you broke all those rules?" Wang Ming was in disbelief. He was sure that they would get evicted.

"Let me finish. Although we're not evicted for now, we can still be evicted. However, the Lord has a request for us, and if we help him fulfill it, he will allow us to continue living here."

"The Lord of the mountain? He's a very powerful man since he owns this place, right? If there's something even he cannot do, this request might be very troublesome." Wang Bingbing said.

"What does he need us to do?" Wang Ming then asked.

"I don't know yet. I will be meeting with the Lord tomorrow for more information."

"You're going to meet with the Lord?!" Chu Liuxiang was shocked to hear this.

The Lord of the Dragon Spiral Mountain is so mysterious that nobody besides the Manager knows his appearance. Although there have been people that met with him before, they were still unable to see his appearance and have only heard his voice.

"I can't believe you're already getting to meet the Lord when most people that have lived here for decades don't..." Chu Liuxiang said in a dumbfounded voice.

"Well, whatever the Lord wants from us, keep us updated." Wang Ming said.

"I will.." Yuan nodded.

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Chapter 745 - Indecent Thoughts

Chapter 745: Indecent Thoughts

"Good night, darling." Chu Liuxiang snuggled beside Yuan when it was time to sleep.

"Night."

After a moment of silence, Chu Liuxiang spoke again, "Can I embrace you while I sleep tonight?"

"Of course."

"Thank you."

Chu Liuxiang wrapped her arms around him and closed her eyes.

Despite her urges to strip naked and procreate with Yuan, she did not want to ruin the peaceful moment right now. Furthermore, now that she is no longer with the Chu Family, she does not have to rush to make a family with him. 6

Of course, that is not to say her desire to make a family has lowered. In fact, her desire to make a family with Yuan is now more intense than ever after what he'd done for her today.

However, now that she has the time to build a relationship with him properly, she wants to take things slowly and more naturally, which wasn't possible before when she was restricted by the Chu Family. 3

Chu Liuxiang quickly fell asleep while hugging Yuan, but Yuan himself was having trouble sleeping.

'Why is my body reacting like this now?' Yuan sighed inwardly as he could feel the area between his legs getting hotter and hotter.

'Is it because of Lulu? But this hasn't happened before...'

In this dead silent room, Yuan's sense of smell and touch increased, and with Chu Liuxiang so close to him, he could only focus on her soft body and sweet body aroma. 1

Due to circumstances in the Yu Family that forced him to live like a slave, he never had the proper chance to grow up, nor did they teach him anything about puberty.

However, now that he's away from the Yu Family and is living life normally, his halted growth is finally showing signs of progression. 1

One can say that Yuan is currently going through puberty, and it is progressing faster than normal due to his incarnations' memories, not to mention the fact that he is always surrounded by beautiful women that could easily trigger mens' beastly nature. 1

Of course, the biggest factor to his growth has to be his experience with Meixiu.

'After doing that thing with Meixiu, my mind cannot help but have weird thoughts that I never had before. Am I going crazy?'

Even now, Yuan has this strong desire to touch Chu Liuxiang's body for some reason, as well as wanting to 'do it' with her, but he cannot comprehend why he was having such inappropriate thoughts.

The sensation of Chu Liuxiang's soft skin, the sweet smell her body was emitting— Yuan's urge to touch Chu Liuxiang grew with every second.

Fortunately, he has mastered self-control after enduring so much bullshit from the Yu Family, allowing him to resist his urges. If it was anybody else in his shoes right now, they would've long submitted to their urges and acted upon his desires. 3

He also tried to cultivate to calm down, but he was unable to clear his mind, so he had to stop.

Eventually, Yuan gave up and had to spend the entire night controlling his urges.

And just when he was beginning to fall asleep, the digital clock's alarm began beeping, signaling that it was almost sunrise.

"Is it already morning? I had such a good sleep that it felt so short. How was your sleep?" Chu Liuxiang woke up shortly after the alarm, but it was not the noise that woke her up— it was because Yuan had to get out of her embrace to leave the bed.

"I couldn't sleep." Yuan said with a bittersweet smile.

"Is it because of what happened yesterday? Don't think too much about it. You did nothing wrong," she said.

"Although I had a lot of things on my mind that prevented me from sleeping, it wasn't because of what happened yesterday." He shook his head.

"Oh? Then what was on your mind?" Chu Liuxiang looked at him with her interest piqued.

"D-Don't worry about it. It was mostly random stuff about Cultivation Online." Yuan did not hesitate to lie. 1

After all, he couldn't tell her that he'd spent all night trying to resist his urges to touch her. That would definitely weird her out and make him sound like a weirdo.

"Even if it's insignificant, I want to hear about it." Chu Liuxiang insisted.

"..." 14

Yuan silently faced Chu Liuxiang for a moment before suddenly speaking in a surprised voice, "Oh! Look at the time! I need to hurry up or I will be late to meet the Lord! See you later, Lulu!" 5

Yuan quickly changed out of his pajamas before rushing out of the room, leaving Chu Liuxiang speechless.

"Why is he acting so weird?" She mumbled to herself before going back to sleep.

After leaving his room, Yuan proceeded to wait outside the house for the Manager.

Many minutes later, Yuan noticed the Manager's presence and immediately used divine sense for confirmation.

"Good morning, Manager." Yuan greeted her with a respectful bow.

"Let's go. The Lord is waiting for you." She said to him before turning around and walking back without stopping.

Yuan immediately followed behind her.

As they walked to the upper levels, they walked past the Chu Family's gates, which gave off a different feeling than yesterday.

About an hour later, they arrived at the peak of the mountain, and to Yuan's surprise, there was a thick fog before him that could not be seen even at the upper levels, almost as though this fog had mysteriously appeared the moment they reached the peak.

"We're almost there. Follow closely behind me or you'll get lost in the clouds." The Manager said before walking into the fog that turned out to be clouds.

'Clouds? Is the mountain even tall enough to reach the clouds?' Yuan wondered to himself since he didn't recall the mountain being this tall, and he followed right behind the Manager.

Upon entering the fog, Yuan sensed a sudden change in the atmosphere, and this sensation gave him a nostalgic feeling for some reason.

'What is this feeling...? It's like I have been here before...' Yuan thought to himself as he continued to follow the Manager. 14

Chapter 746 - Lord of the Dragon Spiral Mountain

Chapter 746: Lord of the Dragon Spiral Mountain

"Why are you just standing there and looking around? There's nothing to see here. How dare you make the Lord wait for you..." The Manager said to him with a frown on her face. 2

"Coming..." Yuan stopped looking around and picked up his pace.

After walking on this cloudy path for about ten more minutes, they arrived at the peak of the mountain.

The peak of the mountain was surprisingly flat, almost as though someone had cut it with a sword.

However, there was a small hill with a cave located in the middle of the mountain, which looked very awkward and out of place, almost like it didn't originally belong there and that someone had moved it there.

"Where's the Lord? I don't see him here." Yuan said after realizing that the peak of the mountain was empty.

"He's resting inside the cave over there. Stand in front of it, but do not go inside, unless you don't care about your insignificant life," she said. 3

Yuan swallowed nervously before approaching the mountain and standing right before it.

Since he cannot go inside, he decided to use his divine sense to look inside the cave.

However, he was unable to see anything, almost as though there was something interfering with his divine sense.

"Save your energy. You won't be able to penetrate this cave with your divine sense." A deep voice suddenly resounded from within the cave.

Yuan's body shook when he heard this voice that was filled with spiritual energy.

"This Lord is definitely an expert! His voice alone carries an abundant amount of spiritual energy! Even Xiao Hua does not have such powerful spiritual energy! But how is that possible? Spirit Master is already considered the peak for this world, but there could be a couple of hidden Spirit Grandmasters in this world such as Lulu's master. However, Xiao Hua is a Spirit King! There's no way someone in our world could surpass that realm!" Yuan was greatly shocked and interested at the same time, and his curiosity for this Lord has reached its peak.

"Anyways... I heard you attacked the Chu Family. You're very daring for a mere Spirit Master." The Lord's voice continued.

"I had good reasons," said Yuan.

"I don't care about your reasons, nor do I care that you'd attacked the Chu Family. I only care about one thing— obeying the rules of the mountain. However, you have ignored my rules and acted on your own accord. What do you have to say for yourself?"

"I have no excuses." Yuan said with a straight face.

"Hmph. Not even going to put up a fight? How boring."

"I know what I did was wrong, but I have no regrets. If I had to do it all over again to help my friend, I would not hesitate, even if it means getting evicted from the mountain. There are plenty of other places we can live in this world, after all."

"..." 10

The Lord remained silent for a good minute before speaking again, "Do you know why I called you here today?"

"You have a request for us, right? If we do it, you'll forgive me for invading the Chu Family." Yuan said.

"Yes, that's right. However, that's an easy question. Let's make the next one a little harder. Now try answering this. Do you know why I allowed you to live on my mountain in the first place?"

"Huh?" Yuan raised his eyebrows at such a question.

"You're aware that only those that have received my approval can enter this mountain, right? In other words, I picked you. Do you know why I picked you?"

After pondering for a moment, Yuan responded, "Because... I am Player Yuan?"

He could only think of his identity as Player Yuan, which has the most influence and significance.

"Hahaha!"

The Lord suddenly began laughing.

"Player Yuan? I don't give a fuck about such a pointless alias! There's only one reason why I allowed you on my mountain! You, who has seemingly zero connections to the Demon Sealing Clan, have managed to kill a demon! Do you understand the significance behind that achievement?"

"This is about the demon?" Yuan was dumbfounded by the situation. He truly didn't expect the demon that he'd killed would be involved in this conversation.

"The Qi Family is one of three ancient families that have served the Demon Sealing Clan since ancient times with both experience and profound knowledge about demons, yet the best they can do is seal demons. You, on the other hand, can kill them! You, alone, are worth more than the entire Qi Family!"

"..." 13

Yuan was left speechless by the Lord's words, and he wasn't sure where to begin with so much information.

"Manager! Get us the crystal!" The Lord suddenly shouted, causing the air to tremble. 1

"Yes!"

The Manager left the place for a few minutes before returning while carrying something in her grasp.

"T-That thing is?!"

Yuan's jaw dropped from shock when he saw what the Manager was carrying.

It was a chunk of crystal that was yellow in color, and there was a hint of red in the center of the crystal.

"Is that what I think it is...?" Yuan asked the Lord while silently praying that he would be wrong.

"Yes, this is a Red Calamity Crystal. It can predict calamities— but it only works when the calamity is influenced by demons. As you can see, this crystal is already yellow with a hint of red. There's going to be another calamity soon, meaning that another demon will be unleashed into this world."

"There are demons sealed within the Dragon Spiral Mountain, and I want you— and your Demon Sealing Faction to deal with the demons. You can either seal them or dispose of them. I personally prefer extermination."

"..." 13

Yuan was speechless once again. Who could've expected that the Lord's request for him would be to kill demons?

"If you accept my request and take care of the demons, I will not only forgive you for breaking the rules, but I will even tell you a little secret

regarding this world and my identity. If that's not enough, I can tell you the true purpose of Cultivation Online and why it was created." 9

"Cultivation Online's true purpose...?" Yuan mumbled in a dazed voice. 2

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Chapter 747 - Inside The Dragon Spiral Mountain

"So your request for us is to deal with these demons, is that correct?" Yuan asked for confirmation.

"Indeed."

"Okay, I will take care of them." Yuan nodded his head and agreed to the Lord's request.

"Eh?"

A dumbfounded noise echoed from the cave, almost as though the Lord was surprised by his response.

"Is there a problem?" Yuan asked.

"No... I just didn't expect you to agree so easily. This is a demon— demons that we're talking about. Even the Qi Family is reluctant to fight with demons unless they absolutely have to." The Lord said.

"Well, what else am I supposed to say? No, I won't help you deal with these demons that could potentially destroy this world? You know, I created the Demon Sealing Faction for a reason. I plan on eradicating every last demon in this world, even if I don't get anything out of it."

After a moment of silence, the Lord spoke again, "Before you make your decision, I would like you to see something."

"Manager. Take him 'inside' the mountain."

"Inside the mountain!? Are you sure?" The Manager appeared to be shaken by his request.

"He will have to see it eventually since he will be fighting the demons for us, so we might as well let him see the scene and fully understand our situation now. There's no point in delaying this issue. The demons are going to come out of their seal, and I don't trust the Qi Family will be able to handle this calamity by themselves." The Lord sighed.

"I understand."

The Manager turned to look at Yuan and said, "Follow me."

Yuan nodded and proceeded to follow the Manager, but they did not go the way he had expected. Instead of going back to where they came from, they went to the other side of the mountain, where a hidden path was located.

After walking for about half an hour, they arrived before this cave entrance that was emitting an ominous atmosphere.

"Before we go inside, I must warn you not to touch anything." The Manager said to him.

"I won't." He promised.

"Let's go."

They entered the cave a moment later, and after walking for some more, they encountered another entrance, but this one was emitting a menacing aura that would make people reluctant to move forward.

When Yuan felt this forbidding aura, his body got the chills, almost as though it was reacting to it.

After taking a deep breath and swallowing down his nervousness, he followed the Manager into the enclosed area on the other side of the entrance.

"T-This is..." Yuan's body shook violently when he realized what he was seeing in this place, and it left him completely speechless.

He could feel multiple emotions flaring up.

Shock, worry, fear, distress, dismay, and above all, powerless.

Meanwhile, in the Chu Family, Senior Qi, who had been sealed for almost an entire day, finally manages to break out of Yuan's seal.

She gasped for air after breaking out of her seal, and her body was soaked in cold sweat.

"That little bastard! How could he humiliate me in such a manner?! He actually kept me sealed for so long! Does he not have even a shred of mercy in him?!" She cried in a low voice.

Even though she was sealed, she was fully conscious and awake. It felt like she was in a prolonged sleep paralysis, and no matter what she did, she could not break free from the seal.

She became more and more worried as time went on that she would remain sealed forever.

"S-Senior Qi! Are you okay?!"

Someone from the Chu Family had been stationed there to monitor her condition, and he immediately approached her when he noticed the situation.

"What is the situation now?! Where's Yuan and Liuxiang?!" She shouted in an angry voice.

"T-They left yesterday after causing havoc in the family. Yuan even crippled the Master's cultivation." The man explained the situation to her.

"What?! He crippled Chu Shijian?! How ruthless!" Senior Qi trembled in fear after learning of this information, and her thoughts of revenge came to a quick halt.

'This man is ruthless and dangerous! If I mess with him anymore, he might kill me!' Senior Qi believed that if Yuan was capable of leaving her sealed — capable of crippling Chu Shijian, then he was also capable of killing her!

"Where is Chu Shijian right now? Take me to him." Senior Qi said to the man.

"Right away!"

Sometime later, they arrived at Chu Shijian's room, where the owner of the room could be seen lying in bed with a sick and frail appearance, and his wife and children were around him, almost like they were at his deathbed.

"Senior Qi... Thank the heavens that you're fine." Chu Shijian said in a relieved voice after seeing her face.

"I was worried that you had died, and I have spent all night thinking about how I should relay this news to your family."

"What about you? You look like you're on your deathbed." Senior Qi said to him.

"I am fine... Because I suddenly lost all of my cultivation, my body has become frail and pathetic. However, I am not going to die. I should fully recover in a few months." Chu Shijian said.

"That's good to hear. But what are you going to do now? Are you going to take revenge?" Senior Qi asked him.

"Haha... Revenge?" Chu Shijian laughed in a low and dispirited voice.

"After losing my cultivation, I stopped caring about many things, and I realized that I could no longer feel some emotions, almost like I'd lost them as well. What will I achieve with revenge? Am I going to get my cultivation back if I avenge myself? I don't care anymore."

Senior Qi was speechless. Is Chu Shijian really going to take this massive slap in the face and do nothing about it? However, she understood his feeling a little. After all, she is also feeling hesitant about taking revenge.

"I understand. Anyways, I will be returning to my family now. My family has been unable to calm down since the Jade Garden's incident, and they believe that more demons will soon break out of their seal. If you need me, send me a message, but I may not be available anytime soon.." Senior Qi said.

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Chapter 748 - Demons Within The Mountain

"I understand. I apologize for getting you mixed up in my family's mess, Senior Qi." Chu Shijian said to her.

"Also, before you leave, please keep the fact that I had lost my cultivation a secret. There are many people out there who wish to see my Chu Family fall, and if they learn that I am no longer a cultivator, they will definitely try to destroy my family."

"You don't have to worry. My lips are sealed." Senior Qi said.

"Thank you very much."

Senior Qi left the place shortly after.

Meanwhile, back at Yuan's side, he had been staring at the scene before him for the past few minutes without moving a single muscle.

"Why... Why are there so many demons here?!" Yuan eventually snapped out of his daze to ask the Manager, who was standing beside him with a calm face, as she was clearly used to seeing this scene.

After a quick count, Yuan counted 11 sealed demons in this place!

When the Lord mentioned 'demons', Yuan had expected to see two or three demons, but to think there are almost a dozen demons sealed within the mountain! It was too much for him to take in at once.

"Why are there so many demons here?" Yuan asked.

"Try guessing. Your guess will be as good as mine."

"..."

Yuan began to walk around the area, silently inspecting the sealed demons.

'They don't have any cracks, which is good, and compared to the demon at the Jaded Garden, their pulses are much calmer.'

"Are you done yet? I don't like this place, so I'd prefer it if we can leave quickly." The Manager said to him.

"Yes, we can leave." Yuan nodded.

They left the cave and returned to the peak of the mountain.

"What do you think? How'd you like the scenery?" The Lord asked Yuan about his experience inside the cave.

"Why are there so many demons sealed there?" Yuan asked.

"Who knows. They were already there when I arrived at this mountain."

"Anyways, after seeing the demons inside the mountain, do you still wish to help us defeat the demons?" The Lord asked him again.

And without hesitation, Yuan nodded, "I do."

"That's good to hear."

"Is there anything else you have for me?"

"One last thing. I want you to meet the Qi Family and cooperate with them to resolve the situation."

"The Qi Family...?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"As I mentioned before, they have been dealing with demons since ancient times. I think they will be of help to you."

Yuan pondered for a moment.

He has been interested in the Qi Family ever since he met Senior Qi, and he wondered if they were related to the Demon Sealing Clan in Cultivation Online.

"Where can I meet the Qi Family?"

"They live on a remote island somewhere in the middle of the vast sea, away from society."

"What...?" Yuan was surprised to hear this information.

"If you wish to visit them, I can have the Manager take you there. However, the Qi Family is very strict when it comes to guests, so you should go there alone."

"I understand. When can we go there?" Yuan then asked.

"I will have to contact the Qi Family first, but it should take a week." The Lord said.

"Okay."

"I will contact you later."

The Manager led Yuan back down the mountain shortly after.

"Why do you wish to kill the demons so badly?" The Manager suddenly asked him as they descended the mountain.

"Because if demons exist, innocent people will suffer. I lost a friend to the demon in the Jaded Garden. I will not let that happen again, and in order for me to achieve that, I must exterminate all demons from this world," he said.

"You know... What you saw today inside the mountain... They might only be a small faction of the real numbers in this world. There could be hundreds, even thousands of demons sealed around the world."

"I don't care if there's a hundred or even a thousand of them. I will not stop hunting them until all of them are removed."

"I see..."

Once they returned to Yuan's residence, the Manager returned back to the mountain.

"Can we trust him?" The Manager asked the Lord.

"I believe so. He has a pure aura."

"Him? A pure aura? I don't believe it. How can someone who had done what he did to the Chu Family have a pure aura?"

"I'm sure he has his reasons."

Meanwhile, after returning home, Yuan gathered everyone in the living room.

"Welcome back, Yuan. How did things go with the Lord? Did you figure out what he wants from us?" Wang Ming asked him.

"I will tell you all about it once everyone is here."

Once everyone was present, Yuan began recalling his conversation with the Lord.

"This might sound shocking, but there are demons sealed within this mountain, and the Lord wants us to take care of them. That is the request."

"W-What...? There are demons on this mountain?" Everyone there stared at him with wide eyes.

"Yes, I saw them with my own eyes—divine sense. There was not one, not two, not three, but 11 demons currently sealed somewhere within the mountain."

"11 demons?!" They exclaimed in a terrified voice.

A single demon was already enough to wreak havoc in the Jaded Garden. They cannot imagine 11 of them running havoc at the same time.

"If that happens, the damages will be catastrophic! Humanity might even be in danger!" Shi Lang said.

"Indeed, there's a good chance the world will end if we let these demons roam freely. However, that is not going to happen because we are going to take care of them."

"This is why I created the Demon Sealing Faction. This is our purpose— to eradicate demons, as I am simply not satisfied with just sealing them."

"But none of us besides you know any demon sealing techniques, and I am still trying to learn the one you gave me. How long do we have until they break out of their seal?" Wang Ming asked.

"I don't know.." Yuan shook his head.

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Chapter 749 - Technique Transmission

"And I know not everyone here has a demon sealing technique, but I am working on that. I will be heading to the Qi Family next week to speak with them," said Yuan.

"What! The Qi Family?! Why are you going there?!" Chu Liuxiang was shocked to hear this.

"The Qi Family is an ancient family that has vast knowledge on demons, and they could help us deal with them. They are like the Demon Sealing Clan in Cultivation Online."

"I don't think they will be willing to help us, especially not after what you did to the Chu Family and Senior Qi. They probably hold a grudge against you now."

"If they're willing to let the demons run wild because of some petty grudge, then we don't need help from them. However, we won't know that until I meet them." Yuan said.

He turned to look at Xi Murong and Wu Zao and continued, "Can you two ascend as soon as possible so that we can head to the Myriad of Techniques? I want to see if they have any demon sealing techniques since that's where I got my Demon Sealing Strike."

"I will ascend today." Xi Murong nodded.

"I will as well." Wu Zao said.

"Good. Then I will see you two at the square later today."

"I am going to study the Demon Sealing Strike some more..." Wang Ming said.

"Hurry up and learn it already so that I can also study it." Wang Bingbing said to him, as she also uses swords.

"Yeah, yeah."

"Anyways, that's all I have for you guys. We're going to be busy until these demons are dealt with." Yuan said to them.

Sometime later, everyone returned to their own rooms to cultivate.

"By the way, if you want us to learn demon sealing techniques, what about that one technique you used on Senior Qi? You didn't need a weapon to use it, so maybe we can learn it as well." Chu Liuxiang suddenly asked him.

"I have thought about that as well, but I don't think that's possible. Although I know the technique, I didn't learn it from a technique manual, so I don't know how I can teach it to you guys."

"Eh? Then how did you learn the technique?" Chu Liuxiang raised her eyebrows.

"Well... It's complicated..." Yuan sighed.

After all, it wasn't as though he could say that he'd learned the technique from memories of his past life.

"Maybe there is a technique that will allow you to write down techniques you already know. How else do you explain why there are so many duplicate techniques out there?"

"You're right... I will ask the experts later." Yuan said.

"Then I am going to cultivate inside Cultivation Online. I still have a lot of catching up to do." Chu Liuxiang said.

"I will come with you." Yuan nodded.

They logged into Cultivation Online a little later. As for Meixiu, she decided to continue cultivating in the real world.

"Feng Feng, Xiao Hua, I have a question." Yuan called the experts out when he logged on.

"What do you need help with?" Feng Yuxiang asked.

"Are there any methods to teach techniques you know to someone else?" He asked them.

"You want to teach someone your techniques?" They looked at him with raised eyebrows.

"Yes, but I don't know how."

"Well, there are two ways you can teach someone your technique. One, you can write down your technique and give it to them, or you can directly send the technique into their head. Of course, they are both techniques that you need to learn yourself."

"I figured... Hopefully, the Myriad of Techniques have these tech—"

Before Yuan could even finish his sentence, Xiao Hua extended her arm at him, and she was holding onto a manual.

"Here you go, Brother Yuan. This technique will allow you to give techniques to others directly."

Yuan immediately smiled, "Thank you, Xiao Hua!"

"..."

Feng Yuxiang silently stared at Yuan for a few moments before opening her mouth to speak, "Young Master, can I say a few things?"

"Huh? Go ahead."

"I don't know why you want to give your techniques to someone, or who you plan on giving them to, but I highly discourage such actions. Your techniques are all incredibly valuable, and they should not be taught to others."

Yuan smiled and said, "I know, Feng Feng. I am not giving away my techniques to just anyone. They are my friends, and I am only teaching them demon sealing techniques."

"Oh... If that's the case, then you don't have to mind me."

Yuan began studying the technique Xiao Hua gave him.

'Technique Transmission... This is actually a Divine-rank technique?' Yuan was surprised to see this sort of technique having such a high rank.

After spending a couple of hours studying the technique, Yuan managed to learn it.

<You have learned Technique Transmission>

[Technique Transmission]

[Rank: Divine]

[Mastery Level: 1]

[Description: Allows you to transmit any learned techniques below Divine-rank to others]

After learning the technique, Yuan went to seek for Chu Liuxiang.

"Lulu, I want to try transferring this technique to you."

"Okay."

Yuan proceeded to activate the technique and tapped on Chu Liuxiang's forehead with his finger that was glowing a subtle light.

The next moment, Chu Liuxiang could feel information entering her head.

"Wow, there's a lot of information flowing inside my head. Is this the technique you used on Senior Qi?" Chu Liuxiang asked after receiving the technique.

"Yes, how is it?"

"I'm, surprised it's only an Earth-rank technique. It looked so powerful."

"Not really. They can be used to seal demons, but it's not as effective as the Demon Sealing Strike. I guess it's like a basic demon sealing technique for beginners."

"I see... That makes more sense."

And she continued, "I guess I will have to put my other techniques on hold for now so that I can learn this one first."

"Okay. Good luck. I will go meet up with the other two and head to the Myriad of Techniques. I should be back by tonight.." Yuan nodded.

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Chapter 750 - Demon Sealing Clan's Grand Library

After transferring the demon sealing technique to Chu Liuxiang, Yuan went to the square to meet up with Xi Murong and Wu Zao so they could also receive a Heaven-rank technique.

"Are you guys ready?" Yuan asked them.

"Yes."

While they walked, Yuan said to Xi Murong, "You have the same name as someone I know in Cultivation Online."

"Eh? Who?"

"A dragon." Yuan said with a smile.

"I mean, it isn't that weird for people to share the same name." Wu Zao said.

"I guess so."

Sometime later, they arrived at the Myriad of Techniques.

Yuan brought them to the fourth floor after they had their destiny examination.

"You guys can go ahead and look for your desired technique. I will meet you all here in a few hours." Yuan said to them before going off on his own.

'There aren't any demon sealing techniques on this floor, but maybe I can seek Senior Bai's help. Hopefully, he's not busy.'

However, there was one problem. He didn't know how to contact Senior Bai.

Although Senior Bai gave him a jade slip, it was only meant for alerting him about the escaped immortals.

"Guess I should ask the workers here..."

Yuan approached the woman working at the desk on the fourth floor and asked her, "Hello, do you know how I can contact Senior Bai?"

The woman looked at him with a dumbfounded face.

"Senior Bai? He's not someone you can just 'contact'..."

"I know, that's why I am asking you if you know any way to contact him." Yuan said, misunderstanding the woman's words.

"Look here. Senior Bai is someone with a very distinguished background. I don't know who you are, but you do not qualify to speak with him."

Yuan sighed and showed this woman his faction symbol.

"We're from the same faction, and he's like a mentor to me."

"Y-You're in the Celestial Overlords?! How is that possible? You should be in Spirit Heaven!" The woman exclaimed in a shocked voice.

Yuan shrugged, "It just happened. Can I speak with Senior Bai now?"

"J-Just a moment..."

The woman looked for a jade slip underneath her desk before asking him, "Your name?"

"Yuan."

"Why do you want to speak with him?"

"I would like to ask him about demon sealing techniques."

"..."

The woman had many questions, but she didn't dare to ask them.

"Give me a moment."

The woman then relayed all of Yuan's information to the jade slip.

"Senior Bai, there is a person named Yuan who would like to ask you about demon sealing techniques."

"Now we wait." She said to Yuan afterward.

A few minutes later, the jade slip began trembling, and the woman immediately picked it up.

"Let me speak with him." Senior Bai's voice resounded a moment later.

"I understand."

The woman handed the jade slip to Yuan.

"Did something happen?" Senior Bai asked him.

"Yes, unfortunately..." Yuan sighed.

"I am currently looking for demon sealing techniques, but I don't know where to acquire them."

"So your problem is related to demons..." Senior Bai mumbled to himself.

After a moment of silence, Senior Bai said, "Alright, I will let you go to 'that' place. You have already learned the Demon Sealing Strike, so there should be no problem if I send you 'there'."

Yuan raised his eyebrows at the way Senior Bai mentioned this place, making it sound quite ominous.

"Where is this place?" Yuan asked him.

"It's a special place within the Myriad of Techniques that can only be accessed by certain people. The Demon Sealing Clan— you should be familiar with them since you learned their technique, right?"

"Yes, I know the Demon Sealing Clan." Yuan confirmed. In fact, he is technically their founder.

"This place is located within the Myriad of Techniques, but it's actually owned by the Demon Sealing Clan, so there are a lot of demon sealing techniques there."

"That sounds like the place I need to go. How do I get there?"

"I will need to create a portal for you, but that will take some time, and I am a little busy right now. Come back tomorrow. I will have it ready by then."

"I understand. Thank you, Senior Bai."

Yuan returned the jade slip to the woman afterward.

"Thank you for the help." Yuan said to her before turning around and walking away, leaving her speechless.

Sometime later, Xi Murong and Wu Zao returned with a technique of their choice.

They went to 'pay' for the techniques shortly after.

"Thank you for the technique, Yuan."

They bowed to him afterward.

"No need to thank me."

Yuan returned to the hotel after Xi Murong and Wu Zao left to study their techniques.

"I'm going to return to the Myriad of Techniques tomorrow to acquire some demon sealing techniques." Yuan said to Chu Liuxiang.

"Do you need me to come with you?"

"It's okay, you can focus on your cultivation."

"I understand."

The following morning, Yuan returned to the Myriad of Techniques.

"Welcome back, esteemed guest." The woman on the fourth floor immediately recognized Yuan and greeted him.

"Good morning."

"Senior Bai's preparations are ready. Can you leave now?" She then asked him.

"Yes, I am ready to leave." Yuan nodded.

"Please follow me."

The woman stood up and brought Yuan to another room.

"There's nothing here..." Yuan said when he saw the empty room.

"Please wait a moment while I contact Senior Bai."

A few minutes later, a golden portal suddenly appeared in the center of the room.

"Try not to cause any trouble there, my little friend." Senior Bai's voice resounded in the room afterward.

"I won't." Yuan said with a smile.

"When you're ready to leave, just go back into the portal you appeared from."

"I understand."

"Good luck."

After taking a deep breath, Yuan entered this portal and disappeared from the Myriad of Techniques.

Ding!

<You have discovered 'Demon Sealing Clan's Grand Library>

"This place is... amazing..."

Yuan mumbled in a dazed voice after seeing the scenery before him.

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Chapter 751 - Demon Sealing Aura

After being transported to the Demon Sealing Clan's Grand Library, Yuan looked around with a look of awe on his face.

Despite the place being titled a 'library', the atmosphere and scenery looked nothing like a library.

The floor was made out of clouds, and the sky was pure golden, giving the place a heavenly and divine atmosphere, almost as though the place was created for celestial beings.

There was a massive building a few hundred meters away from him, and it gave off an exquisite feeling, just like an emperor's royal residence.

It was also quite populated in this place with numerous people of all ages walking in and out of the building, and most of them were wearing similar outfits.

However, when Yuan tried to look at their cultivation, he was shocked to realize that he was unable to see the majority of their cultivation.

These people were clearly cultivators, but if he couldn't see their cultivation, it simply meant that they were all at a level that far exceeded Yuan's own cultivation, hence why he could not see them.

'Although these cultivators are probably not at Miss Xu or Senior Bai's level, they are definitely some of the most powerful cultivators that I have encountered yet.' Yuan thought to himself.

Once he had enough of the scenery, Yuan began approaching the building in the distance.

However, he was stopped at the entrance by a middle-aged man.

"Hey, you, stop right there."

Yuan halted his movements and turned to look at the man.

"I don't sense a badge on you. How'd you get in here?" The man asked him.

"Uh... Senior Bai sent me here." Yuan quickly responded.

"Senior Bai?" The man appeared to be surprised by his response.

"Well, even if Senior Bai sent you here, I cannot allow you to enter the building without a badge." The man said after a moment of silence.

And he continued, "However, you can receive a badge by proving that you are associated with the Demon Sealing Clan."

"How do I prove myself?" Yuan asked.

"You must prove to me that you know at least one demon sealing technique," he said.

"Okay."

Yuan summoned his Empyrean Overlord and proceeded to execute the Demon Sealing Strike on the spot.

The man's jaw dropped wide open afterward, and he cried inwardly, 'He not only has a Soul Weapon, but I have never seen someone execute the Demon Sealing Strike and emit such a powerful demon sealing aura before!'

While Yuan isn't aware, all demon sealing strikes emit this unique aura, and it is exactly this aura that demons are weak against. If a demon is struck by this demon sealing aura, they will become sealed.

With that being said, the demon sealing aura must be strong enough to actually seal the demon. If the aura isn't strong enough, it would only annoy the demon at most without sealing them.

As for Yuan's demon sealing aura, it was so powerful that it attracted the people in the surrounding area, and they became even more interested in him after seeing his low cultivation base.

"How was that? Do I get a badge now?" Yuan asked the man.

"S-Sure..." The man nodded his head with a dumbfounded look on his face. Only an idiot would refuse to give a badge to someone that's brimming with talent as a demon sealer.

The man then handed Yuan a black and gold badge that had the words 'Demon Sealing' flawlessly engraved on it.

"Make sure you bring this the next time you come here." The man said to him.

"I understand. Thank you."

Once he had the badge, Yuan proceeded to make his way into the building.

However, shortly after entering the building, he was stopped again, and it was by a handsome tall young man this time.

"Hey, junior brother, what's your name?" The man asked him.

"Me? Yuan."

"My name's Wan Yu, and I just had to approach you after seeing your display just now. I almost couldn't believe my eyes when I saw your cultivation. You really impressed me. If you're new here, why don't I show you around?"

Yuan looked at this handsome man with a suspicious gaze.

Wan Yu laughed and said, "Don't worry, I am nobody suspicious. Here, look at this."

He showed Yuan a badge and continued, "I am an official lecturer in this place, and it is my job to guide promising demon sealers such as yourself,

hence why I approached you."

Seeing the badge, Yuan decided to trust him for now.

"Okay. Thank you." Yuan nodded.

"Before we start, I must ask you. How long have you been with the Demon Sealing Clan?"

"Well..."

Yuan began pondering for an appropriate answer.

Despite knowing the Demon Sealing Strike, he isn't officially part of the Demon Sealing Clan.

"I'm quite new, I guess..." He eventually said.

"I see, so you're newer than I thought. Of course, that is perfectly fine." Wan Yu said.

And he continued, "How about your knowledge regarding the Demon Sealing Clan?"

"Not much, to be honest."

Yuan didn't want to lie about this since he saw this as a chance to learn more about the Demon Sealing Clan.

"I understand, then I will guide you as though you just entered the clan."

"Let's start with... Why did you come to the Grand Library today? Did you come to learn demon sealing techniques, or are you here to practice with demons?" Wan Yu asked him.

"E-Excuse me? Practice with demons?" Yuan thought he misheard and asked.

"You didn't know? You can practice fighting against demons here. Of course, they are not real demons but artificial demons, but they have the same abilities and weaknesses as demons, so you will have to seal them in order to defeat them. Do you want to try fighting an artificial demon?" Wan Yu said to him.

"I do!" Yuan immediately replied.

This was a great chance for him to practice fighting against demons before the demons in his world break out of their seals.

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Chapter 752 - Artificial Demon

"Alright. Follow me." Wan Yu said to Yuan before taking him to this open area somewhere within the building.

In this open area, there were many groups of people standing in different spots watching cultivators attempt to fight the artificial demons.

'These are artificial demons...?' Yuan's eyes widened when he saw one of these artificial demons for the first time.

They resembled the demons greatly with red skin, horns, a bloodthirsty face, and even a red crystal embedded in their chest.

However, there was one big difference between these artificial demons and real demons— they lacked the bloodthirsty aura that real demons possessed.

Instead, they had this overwhelming aura created from spiritual energy to pressure the cultivator fighting it.

"It appears that all of the artificial demons are occupied. Let's watch them for now. You can also learn something from them." Wan Yu said.

"Okay." Yuan nodded, and he watched these cultivators fight the demons.

After watching these cultivators for about half an hour, Yuan realized something about these cultivators— that they really sucked at sealing these demons.

Despite these cultivators hitting the artificial demons many times with their demon sealing strike, the demons were still able to move and fight back.

"Why aren't the demons being sealed despite getting struck by demon sealing techniques?" Yuan asked Wan Yu.

Wan Yu looked at him with raised eyebrows and said, "If a demon can be sealed with a single strike, the cultivator fighting that demon would be many levels above the demon. Even the most talented demon sealers of our generation require a couple of strikes before they can seal a demon entirely."

"Once you strike a demon with a demon sealing strike, the demon sealing aura will slowly build up inside their body, and once there is enough built up, it seals the demon."

Yuan didn't know what to make of Wan Yu's words, as he'd sealed multiple demons stronger than him with a single strike, and even the Demon Lord that was far stronger than him had succumbed to his demon sealing technique in a single strike, albeit it took a bit for it to take effect.

"However, there was someone who could seal demons with a single strike. In fact, he could seal a thousand demons with a single move. Can you guess who it is?" Wan Yu suddenly said.

"Divine Paragon?" Yuan answered.

"That's right. The founder of the Demon Sealing Clan— Divine Paragon! He was not only the most powerful demon sealer during his era, nobody has been able to get close to his power since then even though millions of years have passed."

"People say he was created by the heavens to deal with the demons, and that's exactly what he did. The cultivation world used to be terrorized and ruled by demons, but when the Divine Paragon showed up, the demons ran in all direction."

"Of course, no matter where they ran, the Divine Paragon would chase them until they pretty much became extinct."

"It's truly unfortunate that the Divine Paragon disappeared without saying a word. Some people still believe that he's still alive somewhere in this boundless universe."

"..."

Yuan remained silent. If they knew that the Divine Paragon had died and reincarnated, not even the heavens would know how they would react.

Sometime later, one of the cultivators there has finally managed to seal the artificial demon.

Once that happened, a figure approached the demon to inspect it.

"Not bad. Your demon sealing aura is quite powerful, this demon will remain sealed for about 500 years." The person said to the cultivator, who appeared to be very happy about his results.

"Who is that?" Yuan asked.

"He's a fellow lecturer like me. We occasionally come here to watch these junior demon sealers and give them pointers." Wan Yu said.

"I see..."

"Who wants to go next?" The lecturer asked.

"Here's your chance." Wan Yu said to Yuan, who nodded and stepped forward.

"I would like to go."

The lecturer turned to look at Yuan, and to his surprise, there was a Spirit Lord in this place.

"Uhh... Give me a minute to adjust the difficulty. Do you want to fight a demon at the Spirit Lord level, or should I make it Spirit Grandmaster?" The lecturer asked him.

"Can you make it Spirit King?" Yuan asked him.

"S-Spirit King?"

Everyone there looked at him with wide eyes.

"Who's this kid? He wants to fight a Spirit King demon as a Spirit Lord? How reckless!"

"He's probably just seeking attention. He won't last a minute."

'As expected... He's an interesting one.' Wan Yu was the only person there that had a smile on his face that didn't give off the feeling of ridicule.

Once the lecturer adjusted the artificial demon's cultivation to that of a first level Spirit King, Yuan stepped into the arena to face the demon.

"Good luck, kiddo!" Wan Yu cheered him on.

It was at this moment the people there noticed Wan Yu's presence.

"Greetings, Senior Wan!" Everybody there greeted him in a respectful manner.

"Don't mind me, I am just here to watch my new friend." Wan Yu said.

"Friend? That Spirit Lord?" The people there were in disbelief.

Meanwhile, Yuan started his fight with the artificial demon.

After summoning his Empyrean Overlord, Yuan attacked the demon without hesitation.

The demon tried to defend itself against Yuan's fierce assault, but it was having trouble doing so, leaving the spectators dazed.

They couldn't believe their eyes— that a Spirit Lord was putting so much pressure on a demon that was an entire realm above him. Even though it was only an artificial demon, it still has the same prowess as a real demon,

so realistically speaking, a Spirit Lord shouldn't be able to push this demon back so far!

"E-Even if he can overpower a demon with pure strength, all of his efforts will be pointless if he cannot seal the demon, as they will simply regenerate all of its injuries." One of the spectators there said, which is 100 percent true.

However, Yuan has only been hitting the demon with normal attacks without using any demon sealing techniques, which puzzled the spectators, Wan Yu included.

While they didn't expect Yuan to use demon sealing techniques with every strike, it also didn't make any sense for him to not use them at all, and this made the spectators' ponder Yuan's thoughts.

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Chapter 753 - Destroying The Artificial Demon

Many minutes have passed since Yuan began fighting the artificial demon, yet he continued to use nothing more than basic sword techniques on the demon.

This puzzled the spectators, as it seemed like Yuan had no intention of sealing the demon for whatever reason.

"What in heavens' name is he doing? It's been almost 15 minutes, yet he hasn't used a single demon sealing technique."

"If you're here to play around, then get out! There are others here waiting to practice!"

"Yeah! Get out! This isn't the place for you to play around!"

The cultivators there began getting frustrated at Yuan for purposefully not sealing the demon.

They have never seen a demon sealer as obnoxious as him until today.

"Calm down, everyone." Wan Yu suddenly said to them in a soothing voice, and he continued, "As far as I can tell, he's doing exactly what this place is meant to do— to allow you to practice fighting against demons without needing to worry about getting killed. Just because he's not using his demon sealing techniques does not mean he's not practicing."

The cultivators there no longer complained about Yuan not using his demon sealing technique, and they decided to watch him for a few minutes before losing interest and going to watch someone else.

Half an hour later, pretty much everyone had lost interest in Yuan's practice session besides 2 people, and they were both lecturers.

"Fellow Daoist Wan, can you tell me why you're so interested in this young man? Besides his impressive raw strength, I don't see anything else from him that's worthy of your attention."

Wan Yu smiled and said, "If you'd seen his demon sealing aura, you would understand. Just be patient. It'll be worth the wait."

"If you say so." The other lecturer nodded.

While Yuan was focused on getting combat experience with a demon, a cold voice suddenly resounded, snapping him out of his focus, "Are you really even a Demon Sealer? You're so pathetic. Hahaha!"

To Yuan's surprise, the artificial demon had suddenly started speaking when it had been silent since the beginning!

Unbeknownst to Yuan, these artificial demons have a function where it will mock the fighter when they cannot seal the demon after a specific amount of time has passed.

They do so in order to put more pressure on the fighter by publicly humiliating them in front of others.

"If you don't hurry up and seal me, I will eat all of your loved ones... Hahaha!"

"Too bad someone as weak as you won't be able to stop me! You're doomed to watch your loved ones die before me!"

When Yuan heard the artificial demon's mockery, something had snapped inside him.

"Shut the hell up!"

Yuan suddenly jumped forward while his aura exploded with fierceness.

This sudden change surprised Wan Yu and the other lecturer.

[Demon Sealing Strike!]

Yuan swung the Empyrean Overlord directly at the artificial demon.

The artificial demon could feel a powerful demon sealing aura coming from the sword, so it reacted by dodging the strike.

However, Yuan's sword suddenly changed direction mid-motion, cleaving the demon's body cleanly in half.

"Hahah! Not bad! But you won't be able to defeat me like—" The artificial demon suddenly stopped speaking when it realized that its body was already beginning to feel stiff, and this feeling expanded through its body within seconds.

When it looked down at its own body, it realized that its regenerative abilities had stopped, and the lower half of its body had already turned into stone completely.

The demon slowly lifted its head to look at Yuan, who held a cold expression on his face, and for the next few seconds, they would quietly stare at each other until the rest of the artificial demon was sealed.

"Heavens..."

Both Wan Yu and the other lecturer uttered in a dazed voice after witnessing this scene.

The other cultivators there had also turned to look at Yuan's area, but nobody there saw the entire thing.

When they looked, the demon was already lying on the ground with its body separated in half and the lower half already petrified. However, they were able to watch the rest of the demon being sealed within seconds.

"W-What the fuck just happened? What did he do to the artificial demon? Did anyone see it?"

"No, I didn't see it. When I looked, the demon was already sealed."

Even though the cultivators there didn't know what happened, they knew that something incredible had happened, as the instructors' faces were filled with awe, not to mention the powerful demon sealing aura that suddenly erupted moments ago, and these cultivators all wished that they'd continued watching Yuan's practice.

"Such a powerful demon sealing aura... Just who is this young man? And where did you find him?" The lecturer beside Wan Yu asked him.

"I found him at the front of the Grand Library when he displayed the Demon Sealing Strike to get a badge to enter this place, and when I asked him, he said that he was new."

The lecturer swallowed nervously, and he approached the sealed demon a moment later.

After inspecting the artificial demon for a few seconds, he shook his head and said, "This artificial demon can no longer be used. It's been completely destroyed. The seal was too powerful."

"What?!"

The cultivators there were shocked to hear this information. They have never heard of an artificial demon being sealed to the point where they could no longer function.

"I-I'm so sorry!" Yuan quickly apologized after realizing the situation.

'I broke another piece of training equipment!' He cried inwardly.

It feels like every time he practices on training equipment, it would inevitably break.

"I will pay for the damages..." Yuan said a moment later while inwardly bracing himself to sacrifice an arm and leg.

However, the lecturer merely laughed at his words and said while waving his hand, "Don't worry about it, young lad. These things are quite old, so I was already thinking about replacing them."

Of course, these artificial demons are maintained every day to make sure they are like new, but the lecturer didn't tell Yuan so that he doesn't feel bad about it.

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Chapter 754 - Demon Sealing Grotto

After Yuan destroyed the artificial demon, the lecturer had someone take away the demon, and since they didn't expect someone to destroy an artificial demon in such a manner, a replacement would not be ready for a few days.

"Umm... Do you mind if I continue practicing with the artificial demons?" Yuan suddenly asked the lecturer, leaving him speechless.

When Yuan saw the lecturer's perplexed face, he quickly continued, "I-I won't break any more artificial demons, I promise! I won't even use my demon sealing techniques! I just want to become more comfortable when fighting demons!"

"If you say it like that, I cannot refuse." The lecturer nodded.

"Thank you, Senior!" Yuan bowed to him before waiting for the next available artificial demon.

While he waited, Wan Yu approached him and started a conversation with him.

"How old are you this year? You look very young."

"I'm 18 years old."

"What? You're that young? I truly wasn't expecting that." Wan Yu thought Yuan was older than he appeared, as that is usually the case in the cultivation world, especially in their realm.

"If you don't mind me asking, which family are you from?" Wan Yu then asked.

"I don't belong to a family." Yuan shook his head.

"Oh? What about a sect?"

"I used to be in a sect, but I am now wandering the Nine Heavens with my friends."

"So you're a rogue cultivator, huh? That's very surprising as well. I thought you would be from some big family or prominent sect."

"With that being said, if you wish to join the Demon Sealing Grotto, you're more than welcomed."

"Demon Sealing Grotto?" Yuan looked at Wan Yu and asked, "What's their relationship with the Demon Sealing Clan?"

"The Demon Sealing Clan came first and was created by the Divine Paragon himself. The Demon Sealing Grotto, however, was created after the founder's disappearance."

"The two of them basically exist for the same purpose— to deal with the remaining demons in the Nine Heavens. However, despite their similar purposes and existence, the two of them are not really that close to each other. In fact, they can even be considered rivals."

"After the founder's disappearance and the fact that demons are no longer a threat to the Nine Heavens and humanity, the Demon Sealing Clan began to decline and grow weaker, yet the clan refused to change and continued their tradition despite the change happening across the world."

"A few higher-ups were fed up with the Demon Sealing Clan's stubbornness, so they left the Demon Sealing Clan to create their own powerhouse, which is the Demon Sealing Grotto that functions more like a sect than a family, and they brought with them many prominent figures from the Demon Sealing Clan, hurting them even further."

"However, despite our rivalry, both the Demon Sealing Clan and the Demon Sealing Grotto share the Grand Library. You can tell us apart from our uniforms."

"Those wearing black and gold are from the Demon Sealing Clan while those wearing black and red are from the Demon Sealing Grotto. As you can see, I am wearing black and red, so I am from the Demon Sealing Grotto."

"Uhhh... I'm not sure. Can you give me some time to think about it since all of this is very new to me?" Yuan said after a moment of silence.

"Of course. Take all the time you need. And I am not saying this to blow our own bubbles, but the Demon Sealing Grotto is currently far stronger than the Demon Sealing Clan. If you join us, we will forge you into a top-tier demon sealer."

Sometime later, Yuan returned to the stage when there was an opening to fight with an artificial demon.

When the spectators saw this, they quickly went to watch Yuan fight the demon, but they became frustrated when Yuan did not use any demon sealing techniques for an entire hour even while being constantly mocked by the artificial demon.

However, they did not want to leave, fearing that they might miss the action again.

Unfortunately for them, Yuan fought until the end without using a single demon sealing technique.

"Fuck! He's definitely doing this on purpose!" The spectators were fuming by the end.

If it weren't for Wan Yu and the other lecturer's presence, these people would've fought Yuan with nothing but their fists.

Meanwhile, after he was satisfied with his practice, Yuan returned to Wan Yu and said to him, "I would like to learn some demon sealing techniques now. I came to this place for this very reason, as well."

"I understand. Follow me." Wan Yu nodded.

As they walked, Wan Yu spoke, "Since you're new here, you are only allowed access to very limited techniques. If you want to learn more techniques, you will need to raise your demon sealer rank."

"You can raise your rank by taking an examination that tests your demon sealing aura and your knowledge of demons. Since you have managed to successfully seal an artificial demon, you're considered an Apprentice Demon Sealer."

"However, if I take into account your demon sealing aura and your performance today, I would rank you as high as an Elite Demon Sealer, which is two ranks above apprentice. Unfortunately, you must take the exam before you can officially be considered as one."

Yuan nodded and said, "I will think about the exam later. For now, I will just look at the available techniques."

Sometime later, Wan Yu led Yuan inside a large room that had multiple jade tablets placed around the room in an orderly fashion.

"What is this place?" Yuan asked.

"You will understand once you take a look at the jade tablets," said Wan Yu.

Yuan nodded and approached one of the jade tablets.

"This technique... Demon Sealing Strike?"

To Yuan's surprise, the jade tablet had the Demon Sealing Strike engraved onto it.

"That's right. These jade tablets are the techniques, and anyone can learn them as long as they have access to the rooms." Wan Yu said.

Yuan didn't say anything else and began looking at all of the jade tablets.

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Chapter 755 - Demon Sealing Clans Decline

"Hmm? This is also the Demon Sealing Strike?" Yuan raised his eyebrows when he saw the second jade tablet.

However, when he read the contents, he realized that it was a completely different technique. Although it functions similarly to his Demon Sealing Strike, this technique was meant for daggers instead of the sword.

When he realized this, Yuan immediately began studying the technique, as this technique would allow him to seal demons with the Starry Abyss so that he no longer needed to rely just on swords.

A few minutes later, Yuan closed his eyes and digested all of the information from the jade tablet.

Ding!

<You have learned Demon Sealing Strike(Dagger)>

<Rank: Heaven>

<Mastery Level: 1>

<Description: Consumes 1,000,000 Qi. Must wield a dagger to activate. An ancient dagger technique used to seal demons>

"Uhh... Did you just learn that technique?" When Wan Yu saw a profound aura suddenly emit from Yuan's body, he realized that Yuan had just comprehended a new technique, but he still asked for confirmation.

"Eh? I thought you said anyone could learn these techniques." Yuan looked at him with a surprised face, misunderstanding Wan Yu's words.

"Yes, you can. I was just surprised at how quickly you learned the technique. You're full of surprises." Wan Yu chuckled.

"Oh, I see. Then can I ask you a few more questions?"

"Of course. Let me hear them." Wan Yu nodded.

"Are there any limitations to how many techniques I can learn from this place?"

"Nope. You can learn as many techniques you want. There are no limitations."

"Great, then my second question is... Are there any rules about this place that I should know about?"

"Yes, there's a few of them, actually." Wan Yu nodded, and he continued, "First, you are not allowed to share these techniques with outsiders."

"Two, you are forbidden from selling or trading these techniques even to fellow demon sealers. You must receive permission to teach other demon sealers. As an official lecturer, I am allowed to teach other demon sealers, but I am limited to what I can teach."

"One last rule you should keep in mind is that these techniques, while they were created to seal demons, they can also seal humans to a certain extent, and if you're caught sealing humans, you will be killed or crippled by the Demon Sealing Clan or the Demon Sealing Grotto."

"I-I understand." Yuan nodded.

Thankfully, he sealed Senior Qi in his own world, not this world.

As for the rule that forbids him from sharing these techniques, Yuan will obviously have to ignore this rule in order to teach the others demon sealing techniques.

Furthermore, he has already broken the rule more than once.

Yuan returned to studying the techniques shortly after, and he wouldn't stop until he learned enough techniques for everyone.

Wan Yu was shocked when he saw this.

'Why in heavens' name does he need to learn this many demon sealing techniques? It's almost like he's learning a technique for every weapon out there!' Wan Yu cried inwardly.

An hour later, Yuan returned to Wan Yu and said to him, "I will be leaving now. Thank you for helping me today. I learned a lot."

"You're leaving already?"

"I will be back tomorrow to practice some more with the artificial demons." Yuan said.

"Alright. If you ever need anymore help and I am here, you can always come to me." Wan Yu nodded.

"I will."

Yuan left the Grand Library shortly after and returned to the hotel.

"Lulu, I am going to try and cultivate Technique Transmission in the real world so that I can transfer the techniques to everyone later." Yuan said to her.

"Okay, I will stay here until dinner then."

Thus, Yuan logged off by himself and began trying to learn Technique Transmission in that world as well.

Once it was time for dinner and everyone gathered in the dining room, Yuan told them the news.

"I have acquired a demon sealing technique for everyone here, but I will need a few days to learn a technique that will allow me to transfer the techniques directly into your mind."

"Although we can do this in Cultivation Online, I am not really supposed to share these techniques, so I'd rather do it in this world. It might also be a little quicker if we do it this way."

"That's fine. Take all the time you need." They said to him.

The following day, Yuan returned to the Demon Sealing Clan's Grand Library, and he went straight to the area with the artificial demons.

'There's already people here?'

Despite arriving shortly after sunrise, all of the artificial demons were already occupied, so Yuan could only wait.

While he waited there and watched the others practice, the lecturer from yesterday noticed Yuan and approached him.

"Young man, I never got your name yesterday."

Yuan turned to look at the middle-aged man standing beside him and said, "My name's Yuan."

"Yuan, huh? I am Tang Zheng, an official lecturer here for the past ten years. I haven't seen you here before until yesterday. How long have you been a demon sealer?"

"Not long."

"That's perfectly fine. Despite being new, you have a very impressive demon sealing aura, especially for someone at your cultivation base. Do you belong to the Demon Sealing Clan or the Demon Sealing Grotto?" Tang Zheng asked.

"I'm not actually officially affiliated with either." Yuan said.

"I see, so you're from one of the branch families. If you want, I can recruit you into the Demon Sealing Clan right now, unless you've already been recruited by Wan Yu. It would be a pity if that was the case."

"Pity? Why would it be a pity?" Yuan asked with a questioning gaze.

"As everyone is aware by now, the Demon Sealing Clan is declining. We're currently in our weakest state ever since the clan's creation. At this rate, the Demon Sealing Clan will continue to decline until it's inevitable end, hence why we're recruiting any talent we can find."

"If you join the Demon Sealing Grotto, that's one less talent we have and one more step towards our doom, which is an immense pity since the Demon Sealing Clan is the reason the cultivation world is so peaceful today."

Chapter 756 - Legend Of The Divine Paragon

"Well... Although Senior Wan has indeed offered me to join the Demon Sealing Grotto, I have not decided to join them yet. As for the Demon Sealing Clan, I would also like to think about it some more." Yuan responded to Tang Zheng's offer.

"Of course. Take all the time you need." Tang Zheng nodded with a relieved smile on his face.

As long as Yuan doesn't accept Wan Yu's offer, he still has a chance to recruit Yuan into the Demon Sealing Clan.

And while some might think Tang Zheng was exaggerating the Demon Sealing Clan's situation to trick Yuan into joining them, it is a fact that the clan has been in a straight decline ever since their founder disappeared.

As for their reason for decline, it is actually much simpler than one would expect.

The Demon Sealing Clan was created for the sole purpose of fighting demons, and after killing or sealing most demons and chasing the rest into hiding, the Demon Sealing Clan became less relevant as they were no longer needed due to the lack of demons.

In the end, the downfall of demons was also the downfall of the Demon Sealing Clan.

'I am the reincarnation of the founder of the Demon Sealing Clan, so I should join them and save them from their ruin. However, I am no longer

the Divine Paragon, and I shouldn't let my past affect my current life...'

Yuan was in a predicament. On one hand, he wants to help the Demon Sealing Clan that he'd created in his past life. However, on the other hand, he didn't want to let his past lives to continue affecting his current life, as he fears that he might lose his personality and become someone unrecognizable.

After pondering for some time, Yuan temporarily stopped thinking about it to step onto the stage to fight the artificial demon.

"What's that kid doing? He's not using any demon sealing techniques."

Since it was a new day, there would naturally be new people in the area that didn't know about Yuan.

"Who? Oh, him? He was also here yesterday doing the exact same thing as he is doing right now. I guess he just wants to experience fighting demons without actually sealing them. A waste of our time if you ask me. After all, what's the point of fighting demons if you don't seal them?"

Someone there recognized Yuan and explained to those asking.

Eventually, the artificial demon began mocking Yuan for not being able to seal it.

"Haha! What's wrong, demon sealer? You can't even seal a fake demon? How will you survive if you encounter a real demon that is far more powerful than a fake? You should give up and just return to being a normal cultivator!"

Of course, Yuan ignored the artificial demon's taunting and continued to slice its body with the Empyrean Overlord.

Once Yuan was satisfied with his workout a few hours later, he stopped fighting the artificial demon.

"Finally! I thought he was going to stay up there for the entire day!" The people there sighed in relief when they noticed that Yuan was finally

leaving, allowing them to fight the artificial demon.

Tang Zheng, who'd just come back to the area from eating lunch, noticed Yuan and quickly approached him.

"Yuan, are you free right now?"

"Sort of. Why?" Yuan asked.

"I'd like to show you something."

"Okay."

Yuan didn't question Tang Zheng and followed him to another area within the Grand Library, arriving at another empty square shortly after.

However, the place was empty in the sense that there was a lot of space in this area, since there were actually a lot of cultivators scattered around this place with most of them seated around this domineering statue.

Yuan's eyes widened with surprise when he saw this statue that was located at the center of this empty square, as he'd seen the face of this statue before, mostly in his dreams.

"That's... the Divine Paragon?" Yuan mumbled in a low voice.

When Tang Zheng heard it, he smiled and said, "That's right. He is the founder of the Demon Sealing Clan and the idol of every demon sealer in existence— Divine Paragon, also known as the Bane of Demons."

"When I was a young cultivator, I happened to overhear a legend about him, and because of this legend, I decided to become a demon sealer. I never looked back nor have I ever regretted my decision. Do you want to hear it?"

"Sure." Yuan nodded.

"When demons were still rampaging in the Nine Heavens, millions of demons dwelled within this impenetrable stronghold in the Demonic Realm that was deemed impossible to conquer by all cultivators."

"However, the Divine Paragon, all by himself, entered the Demonic Realm for a total of 66 days. The world thought the Divine Paragon had died inside the Demonic Realm, but to everyone's shock, the Divine Paragon returned from the Demonic Realm, and that's when everyone learned the truth— that the Divine Paragon had been killing demons nonstop since he entered the hellhole."

"In just two short months, he'd conquered the Demonic Realm and killed every single demon inside, something everybody had deemed impossible. Nobody has entered the Demonic Realm since then, as the Divine Paragon had sealed the Demonic Realm just in case he missed a few demons."

"Demon sealers nowadays would have trouble fighting a single demon even in a group, yet the Divine Paragon had killed millions of demons all by himself in two short months. If you ask me what a real demon is, I would, without hesitation, say it's the Divine Paragon... in a good sense."

Yuan was speechless after hearing this legend.

'No wonder why demons are terrified of him... He's actually more devious than demons!' He sighed inwardly.

"Hmm?" Tang Zheng suddenly raised his eyebrows at Yuan, almost as though he'd realized something.

"Yuan... Now that I look at you closely, you look awfully similar to the Divine Paragon's statue over there, almost like you're a younger version of the Founder himself."

"Eh?"

When Yuan heard Tang Zheng's outrageous yet accurate claims, Yuan's body froze, almost as though he'd been sealed.

Chapter 757 - Advanced Demon Sealer Examination

"Good heavens, the longer I look at you, the more I get the feeling that you look like the founder." Tang Zheng subconsciously moved his face closer to Yuan's face to get a closer look.

Yuan took a few steps back and said in a stiff voice, "You're probably just seeing things..."

"No! I am certain! You have such an eerie resemblance to the Divine Paragon! If I didn't know any better, I would say that you're a reincarnation of him!" Tang Zheng said, unaware that he was 100 percent correct.

"You know what? This could be a sign the heavens have sent us—that you could potentially become the next founder of the Demon Sealing Clan! With your talents, it's definitely doable! Yuan! You must join the Demon Sealing Clan! You, who bears the founder's face, cannot allow the Demon Sealing Clan to disappear!" Tang Zheng stared at Yuan with eyes full of emotions.

He was someone easily influenced when it comes to the Divine Paragon, and with Yuan having so much resemblance to the Divine Paragon, Tang Zheng truly believed that Yuan was sent by the heavens to save the declining Demon Sealing Clan.

"Even if you tell me that..."

Yuan had intentions to join either the Demon Sealing Clan or the Demon Sealing Grotto, but he wasn't sure which one he should join.

On one hand, the Demon Sealing Grotto is much more powerful than the other option, but on the other hand, he had technically created the Demon Sealing Clan, so it wouldn't be right to let them disappear.

While Yuan pondered, a familiar voice suddenly resounded inside his head, "Join the Demon Sealing Clan."

Yuan recognized this voice to be the Divine Paragon's voice, and he turned to look at the Divine Paragon's statue.

In Yuan's eyes, the Divine Paragon's statue had turned into a real person and was no longer a statue.

"There are secrets within the Demon Sealing Clan that only I know of. If you let it disappear, these secrets will also disappear, and there's a good chance that the Nine Heavens will return to chaos if you do not return to the Demonic Realm."

'Demonic Realm? What does that have anything to do with joining the Demon Sealing Clan?' Yuan frowned.

"If you wish to learn the truth, you must enter the Demonic Realm."

'The Demonic Realm that you sealed?'

The Divine Paragon did not respond and returned to being a statue.

Yuan sighed out loud and turned to look at Tang Zheng.

"Will it be problematic if I join the Demon Sealing Clan while already being in a faction?" Yuan asked.

"Faction? No, there won't. The Demon Sealing Clan is not considered to be a family, a sect, nor a faction, so there shouldn't be any problems."

Yuan raised his brows and asked, "If the Demon Sealing Clan is not any of these things, what is it?"

"Honestly, I am not too sure either, but the Divine Paragon never considered the Demon Sealing Clan to be any of these things. It used to be a place where anyone could join as long as they wanted to fight demons. Things have obviously changed since then, so it resembles a faction more than anything. With that being said, we're not considered a faction, and even if we are considered a faction, there shouldn't be any problem since most factions allow their members to join multiple factions as long as that faction is not an enemy."

"As for the Demon Sealing Grotto, they are a faction, and they have a sect as well."

Yuan nodded and said, "Then I will join the Demon Sealing Clan—temporarily, if you don't mind."

"May I ask why only temporarily?"

"Just in case I change my mind."

"I can assure you that you will not regret your decision, but if you insist, that is fine. You can join us temporarily. We don't have any rules that forbid our members from leaving once they join, anyway."

"Okay."

"Now that you are part of our Demon Sealing Clan, let's get you your uniforms and badge."

Yuan followed Tang Zheng to another place, where he would receive three sets of uniform and a badge.

"There's no rule about wearing the uniforms, so you don't have to wear them if you don't want to. As for the badge, it is proof that you are part of the Demon Sealing Clan. You will need it if you want to enter any of our establishments."

"How is this badge any different from the one I received in front of the Grand Library?" Yuan asked.

"The Grand Library's badge will only allow you to enter this place, and it just means you're affiliated with the Demon Sealing Clan."

"I see..."

"Anyways, you're currently an Apprentice Demon Sealer, but I have seen you defeat an artificial demon, so you qualify for the next rank. Would you like to take the examination now and become an Advanced Demon Sealer?" Tang Zheng then asked him.

"If I become an Advanced Demon Sealer, I will get to learn more demon sealing techniques, right?" Yuan asked.

"That's right. You'll get to learn Divine-rank demon sealing techniques."

"Then I will take the examination." Yuan nodded.

"Great. Follow me."

Tang Zheng led Yuan back to the area with the artificial demons and said to him, "Wait here while I grab two more official lecturers to witness in the examination. We need at least three lecturers."

After Tang Zheng left, Yuan spectated the other cultivators while he waited.

About fifteen minutes later, Tang Zheng returned to him with two other individuals, an old lady and a beautiful young woman.

"Tang Zheng, you dragged me here for an Advanced Demon Sealer examination during my lunchtime. I really hope it's worth it, or you'll regret wasting my time." The beautiful woman said to him as they entered the area.

"Don't worry, it will definitely be worth it. I dragged you here because I knew how much you both admire the founder. Once you see this young—"

Before Tang Zheng could even finish his sentence, the old woman suddenly exclaimed in a shocked voice, "Divine Paragon?!"

Sure enough, the old lady noticed Yuan standing in the crowd and mistook him for the Divine Paragon.

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Chapter 758 - Little Founder

"What the? Did you just say Divine Paragon? Have you finally gone senile from old age?" The beautiful woman raised her eyebrows when she heard the old lady's words.

After all, how could the Divine Paragon suddenly appear in the Grand Library?

The woman subconsciously turned to look at the direction the old lady was looking at, and to her absolute shock, someone who looked exactly like the Divine Paragon stood in the crowd!

As fanatics and admirers of the Divine Paragon, they have engraved every detail of the Divine Paragon into their souls, so they knew right away when they saw Yuan's face that he looked exactly like the Divine Paragon.

"Wait..." Before Tang Zheng could even open his mouth properly, the two women rushed through the crowd and directly at the unaware Yuan.

Yuan, who was minding his own business, suddenly felt two aggressive presence behind him, causing him to turn around.

When he did, he could see two women with glowing eyes running in his direction.

Naturally, this startled Yuan, who could only wonder who these women were and why they were running at him.

However, before he could even react, the old lady suddenly disappeared from her spot and appeared right beside him like a ghost.

"What the?!"

Right as Yuan turned to look at the old lady, he suddenly felt someone touch his cheeks, who also turned his head.

"Wow! You really look like the Divine Paragon! What's your name? And where did you come from, handsome?" The beautiful woman asked Yuan as she held his cheeks with her smooth hands, looking like an owner and her dog.

"Uhh... My name's Yuan..." He responded in a dazed manner.

"What in heavens' name do you two think you are doing to my new recruit?!" Tang Zheng suddenly appeared to drag them away from Yuan.

He then said, "I apologize for this, Yuan. They've been long-time admirers of the Divine Paragon, and since you look so similar to him, they went crazy."

"What do you mean he 'looks similar'? He looks exactly like the Divine Paragon, albeit a lot younger!" The beautiful woman said.

"I know that, hence why I brought you two here. However, if you're going to bother him, I will find new instructors for his examination!" Tang Zheng sighed out loud.

"Why are you being so annoying, Tang Zheng? We're not bothering him at all." The old lady cleared her throat before speaking.

"As for the examination, do we really need to do it? I can tell by his appearance alone that he will easily pass the examination."

"Senior Fu is right. There's no way that someone with the Divine Paragon's face could fail such an easy exam." The beautiful woman said.

Tang Zheng rubbed his temples and said, "I also know he can pass the examination since I have already seen him seal an artificial demon, but we still need to do an official examination. It will look bad on us if we don't do this."

"Whatever." The beautiful said before turning to look at Yuan with a friendly smile, "My name is Yan Hara. Let's talk more after your examination, handsome."

"Sure..."

After winking at Yuan, Yan Hara turned to look at the cultivators that were currently fighting an artificial demon.

"Hurry up and seal the demon already! If you make the little founder wait too long, I will go up there and seal the demon for you!"

When the cultivators and the spectators heard Yan Hara's words, they turned to look at them.

"Little founder?"

They all focused on Yuan, and sure enough, they could see a strong resemblance of the Divine Paragon from him.

"Heavens... Why didn't I notice this earlier? He really looks like the Divine Paragon's statue."

"He looks so much like the founder that I wouldn't doubt it if you told me he was a direct descendant of the founder..."

"What if he is a descendant?"

"That's not possible. They said the founder had no Dao Companion."

"That doesn't mean anything! For all we know, the founder could've found a Dao Companion after his disappearance!"

"Fuck... If you say it like that..."

Soon enough, pretty much everybody in the area was talking about Yuan's resemblance to the Divine Paragon.

A few minutes later, one of the cultivators there finally sealed the artificial demon and stepped off the stage.

He turned to look at Yuan and smiled, "The stage is all yours, little founder."

"Thank you..." Yuan didn't know how he felt about being called 'little founder'.

Ignoring their accuracy, it just felt weird.

Sometime later, Yuan stepped onto the stage, and all of the spectators in the area gathered around him to watch his examination.

"Before we begin, allow me to give you the rules." Tang Zheng said.

And he continued, "In order to pass the examination and become an Advanced Demon Sealer, you must seal an artificial demon that is two realms below your cultivation base within the time limit, which is thirty minutes."

"What...?" Yuan was dumbfounded to hear the passing condition, as it sounded way too easy.

"Two realms below my cultivation base within 30 minutes? Why is it so easy?"

Since he is a Spirit Lord, his artificial demon, which will be two realms lower, will only have the strength of a Spirit Master! He could seal a demon at this level even in his sleep!

Of course, while this examination might be incredibly easy for someone like Yuan, not all demon sealers are as talented as him.

While Yuan wouldn't have any trouble fighting demons above his cultivation base, he is an abnormal existence. Meanwhile, normal demon sealers would have trouble with demons even one realm below their own cultivation base.

Therefore, if they made the examination too hard, nobody would be able to rank up. With that being said, even with an artificial demon two realms below the examinee's cultivation base, there are still many cultivators out there that would struggle against it.

However, even though the examination was incredibly easy for Yuan, it wasn't as though he was completely free of worries.

In fact, he had one major problem regarding this examination.

'If I hit it with my demon sealing techniques, I will definitely break another artificial demon... What should I do?' He sighed inwardly.

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Chapter 759 - Advanced Demon Sealer

"That's all you need to know for the examination. You may begin now."
Tang Zheng said to Yuan a moment later.

Yuan nodded, but he didn't immediately attack the artificial demon. As for the demon, it also won't attack Yuan until he makes the first move.

"What are you waiting for, little founder? The examination has already started." Yan Hara said to him.

"Umm... There's a good chance that I will break the artificial demon." Yuan said.

It was at this moment that Tang Zheng recalled Yuan's prowess yesterday that completely destroyed an artificial demon.

Although losing one artificial demon isn't a huge loss, they are not cheap either, and if they lose two artificial demons back to back in two days, the maker of these artificial demons will become annoyed at them.

However, before Tang Zheng could even say anything, Yan Hara spoke out loud, "Don't worry about breaking them! They're very durable and have the same regenerative ability as real demons, so no matter how you slice or dice it, you won't break it."

Of course, Yan Hara has no idea that Yuan had already destroyed an artificial demon just yesterday.

And she continued, "Even if you somehow manage to break it, we can easily get a replacement, so go ahead and break it!"

Yuan nodded his head and didn't say anything else.

He turned to look at the artificial demon with a calm gaze.

'I should try out the Demon Sealing Strike for the dagger.'

With this thought in his mind, Yuan summoned the Starry Abyss in its invisible mode and used it to attack the demon.

'An invisible dagger? It is also emitting the aura of a Soul Weapon... He can actually control two Soul Weapons at once?' Tang Zheng was greatly shocked by this new information.

He witnessed Yuan's Empyrean Overlord yesterday, and the fact that Yuan is using a different Soul Weapon today could only mean that he has multiple Soul Weapons, which is incredibly rare even in the upper heavens.

Whoosh!

The invisible Starry Abyss flew at the artificial demon and struck it directly between its eyes a split second later.

The artificial demon fell to its knees the next second and remained there, which puzzled the spectators, as they wondered why the artificial demon wasn't standing back up.

However, they would soon get their answer when the artificial demon began turning into stone at a rapid rate.

A few seconds later, the artificial demon was completely sealed.

"What in heavens' name..."

Everyone there except Tang Zheng was shocked to witness Yuan sealing a demon with a single demon sealing strike.

"As expected of our little founder... His demon sealing aura is quite ridiculous for someone at his level! Maybe he's really the reincarnation of the Divine Paragon..." Yan Hara mumbled to herself in a low voice.

Once Yuan sealed the demon, Senior Fu went to inspect the demon, and to her shock, the artificial demon was completely sealed, including its core, which renders the entire thing useless.

All artificial demons have a core that allows it to function and gives them their regenerative ability, and this core was specifically made to resist demon sealing aura so that it doesn't break everytime someone seals the demon.

However, Yuan's demon sealing aura had somehow managed to penetrate the core's defenses and sealed it alongside the demon.

"This artificial demon is no longer usable." Senior Fu announced the results to Yan Hara and Tang Zheng, who wasn't surprised at all.

As for Yan Hara, she was dumbfounded and amazed at the same time.

She has witnessed thousands of examinations, yet this is her first time encountering someone that has managed to destroy an artificial demon so thoroughly.

"Congratulations on passing your examination, Yuan. You're now officially an Advanced Demon Sealer!" Tang Zheng said to him a moment later, breaking the awkward silence.

"Thank you." Yuan said.

Even though the examination was a little too easy, at least he gets to learn more demon sealing techniques.

"Come with me, little founder. We're going to get you your new badge." Yan Hara suddenly grabbed Yuan and began pulling him away.

"W-Wait for me!" Senior Fu quickly followed.

Tang Zheng shook his head with a bittersweet smile on his face, and he also followed them.

Meanwhile, a new rumor began spreading around the Grand Library.

"Have you heard? There's a demon sealer who looks exactly like the founder of the Demon Sealing Clan, and he managed to destroy an artificial demon."

"Huh? The Divine Paragon? It must be an exaggeration."

"It's not. A lot of people have seen him, and they all agreed that he looks just like Divine Paragon, albeit a lot younger. They even gave him the nickname 'little founder'."

"I won't believe it until I see him with my own eyes. As for destroying an artificial demon, it's not really that impressive if you think about it. The artificial demons in the Grand Library are merely low-quality puppets. Most Elite Demon Sealers can destroy them if they try hard enough."

"It may not seem impressive because I didn't mention his cultivation. The little founder is only a Spirit Lord, and he just became a demon sealer not long ago. Hell, he just passed his examination and became an Advanced Demon Sealer."

"What? What is a Spirit Lord doing in the Grand Library? And he destroyed an artificial demon as an Apprentice Demon Sealer? Now I definitely don't believe you."

"Suit yourself. This information is already spreading throughout the Demon Sealing Clan and even the Demon Sealing Grotto. It will only be a matter of time before the higher ups set their eyes on him. Even though he's already joined the Demon Sealing Clan, it won't stop the Demon Sealing Grotto from trying to snatch him from them, as it has happened multiple times before already. I cannot wait to see where this goes."

While news of the 'little founder' spread, Yuan received his Advanced Demon Sealer badge.

"Little founder, why are you not wearing your uniform? I want to see you in the Demon Sealing Clan's uniform! Hurry up and change!" Yan Hara urged him afterward, sounding a little impatient for some reason.

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Chapter 760 - The Next Divine Paragon

"Hurry up, little founder! I want to see you standing beside the Founder's statue while in your uniform!" Yan Hara continued to urge him despite the weird looks he was giving her.

"Yuan, I suggest you give up and fulfill her wishes. She's one of the most stubborn people in this place, and she will bother you until you do it." Tang Zheng patted him in the back and said.

Of course, he also wanted to see Yuan standing beside the Founder's statue so that they can get a side-by-side comparison.

"I just need to wear the uniform, right? I will do it under one condition." Yuan suddenly said.

"What condition?"

"You will answer my question."

"That's easy! You can even ask for my three sizes and I won't refuse!" Yan Hara said in a prideful voice.

"Your what?" Yuan raised his eyebrows, as this is his first time hearing such a term.

Tang Zheng loudly cleared his throat and said, "Ignore her teasing. Anyways, if you have any questions, I will be happy to answer them even if you don't fulfill her request."

"Please! I am begging you! Look! I will even get on my knees and beg—" Yan Hara began lowering her body.

When Yuan saw this, his eyes widened, and he quickly said, "Fine, I will do it."

"Don't you have any sense of shame, Yan Hara? How can you beg in such a manner? To a junior, no less." Tang Zheng shook his head.

"I won't do this just for anyone! You have no idea how I feel!" She coldly snorted.

Sometime later, Yuan left to change his clothes.

When he returned, the three seniors were so surprised by his appearance that they had become speechless.

After wearing the Demon Sealing Clan's uniform, Yuan's aura changed significantly, and he looked even more like the Divine Paragon.

"I cannot wait!"

Yan Hara suddenly grabbed Yuan and flew directly to the area with the Divine Paragon's statue.

Tang Zheng and Senior Fu quickly followed.

Once they arrived, Yan Hara placed Yuan right beside the statue and said to him, "Stand right here for a minute."

"Okay..." Yuan nodded in a dazed manner, feeling like he was being treated as some sort of toy.

"Aaaaaah!" A sharp noise suddenly resounded in the area, causing everyone there to look at Yan Hara, who had just screamed.

They all wondered why she was screaming, but when they looked at Yuan, who she was staring at, they all understood why she'd just screamed.

Yan Hara is a renowned Divine Paragon fanatic in the Grand Library, and seeing someone who looks so identical to the Divine Paragon while also standing right next to his statue, it was only natural that she would go crazy.

In fact, when other fanatics saw Yuan standing right beside the Divine Paragon's statue, they also screamed like fangirls.

"Aaaah! It's the Divine Paragon!"

"What?! No way! He's really here!"

"Are you really the Divine Paragon?!"

"You look a little too young to be the Founder. Are you, by any chance, his descendant?!"

A crowd quickly gathered around Yuan and the statue, blocking Yan Hara's view.

Yan Hara began fuming when these random people blocked her view, causing her to release a powerful pressure that also carried a hint of killing intent.

"Get away from him! If you're going to watch, do it where you're not blocking others' view!"

The people there quickly scattered away from Yuan when they heard Yan Hara's angry voice and felt the threatening aura.

However, they didn't completely leave the area and decided to watch from a distance.

"Is he a gift from the heavens, or are they simply mocking us?" Senior Fu mumbled in a dazed voice as she looked at Yuan's face and the Divine Paragon's statue back and forth, and the longer she stared, the more she believed that they were the same person.

"I have heard of many rumors about doppelgangers, but I have never witnessed anything like that in my life until today." Tang Zheng sighed.

"Although he's a little young right now, in a few years, he will look even more like the Founder. When that happens, it will be as though the Founder has returned to us..." Yan Hara spoke as tears flowed down her cheeks.

The place quickly filled with murmurs.

Meanwhile, Yuan felt incredibly awkward. This situation made him recall his days in the Yu Family, when he was admired by countless people. The way these people looked at him like he was their savior, it brought back bad memories.

However, he didn't blame them, nor does he find any fault in their reaction, mostly because he was actually their 'Founder'.

"I have decided." Yan Hara suddenly said.

And she continued in a loud voice, "I, Yan Hara, will make it my life's mission to make you the next Founder of the Demon Sealing Clan!"

"What?!"

Tang Zheng and the others looked at her with wide eyes after her bold declaration.

"Yan Hara, I know you're excited and all because he looks like the Founder, but you're going a little too far here... You should calm down and rethink this." Tang Zheng said to her.

"I am perfectly calm! In fact, I have never been any clearer! He has not only the looks but also the talents to become the next Divine Paragon! I am sure of that after witnessing everything today!" Yan Hara said.

Tang Zheng could only shake his head at her words, as he knew that it was impossible to change her mind once she's in this kind of mood.

"Yan Hara, I know your feelings, but it's not going to be an easy task." Senior Fu said to her.

"I know, but it's not like I have anything else better to do. I have been getting bored as a lecturer, anyway." She shrugged.

"Bored...? You've only been a lecturer for four years..." Senior Fu said.

"Who cares about such minor details?" Yan Hara laughed as she approached Yuan.

"Little founder! I have some good news for you! I, Yan Hara, the most talented demon sealer in my generation, have decided to train you to become the next Divine Paragon!" She stood before him while surrounded by a prideful aura.

After hearing her words, Yuan only had one question for her— "Why?"

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Chapter 761 - Red Tyrant

"Why? What do you mean 'why'? Don't you want to become the best demon sealer in the Nine Heavens?" Yan Hara looked at Yuan with wide eyes, almost as though she couldn't believe he'd even ask such a thing.

And she continued, "Although I may not be the best demon sealer or the best teacher out there, I am definitely a renowned demon sealer with vast experience. I even killed 3 real demons before. If you study under me, I can guarantee you that you will become a great demon sealer."

"Only three demons?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"A-Are you looking down on me?! Three demons may sound very little, but you must consider how demons are almost extinct! Most demon sealers nowadays have not even encountered one real demon, much less kill three!" Yan Hara could see a hint of disappointment in Yuan's gaze and quickly defended herself.

"S-Sorry, I didn't mean it..." Yuan quickly apologized when he realized that he'd just been disrespectful to her.

Yuan was someone who had killed multiple demons, and his kill count was even higher than Yan Hara, which he didn't expect as a newbie.

However, just because he killed more demons than Yan Hara did not mean he had more experience than her, and upon realizing this, he gave it some serious thoughts.

'I will have to face 11 demons in the near future, so I should acquire as much experience as I can before then...'

After thinking about it for a moment, Yuan eventually nodded his head and said, "Okay, I will better myself as a demon sealer. However, I am not doing this because I want to become the next founder. I just want to be able to defeat demons if I ever come across them."

Yan Hara, who had been a little dejected suddenly became elevated after hearing Yuan's words.

Even though he doesn't have the aspiration to become the next Divine Paragon, it was more than enough for her that he wanted to study under her since he might change his mind in the future.

"Great! Starting today, you are my disciple! Of course, it won't be anything formal." Yan Hara said with a bright smile on her face.

"I understand, Senior Yan."

"Anyways, you had some questions, right? I can answer them now if you want." Yan Hara said to him, not forgetting about his matters.

"Yes, I wanted to learn more about the Demonic Realm." Yuan said.

"The Demonic Realm?" Yan Hara looked at him with a questioning gaze.

"Although that place hasn't been relevant ever since the Divine Paragon sealed it, I guess it's good to learn about its history."

"Follow me, I will teach you everything you want to know about the Demonic Realm."

Yuan nodded and followed Yan Hara to this room that gave off the atmosphere of a library.

"Go wait over there for me. I will grab some ancient scrolls about the Demonic Realm." Yan Hara pointed at an empty table in the room.

Yuan walked to the table and proceeded to wait for her.

A couple of minutes later, Yan Hara returned and placed a couple of scrolls on the desk.

"Alright, let's begin, shall we?"

"Yes." Yuan nodded.

"Let's start with the beginning."

Yan Hara placed a scroll before him and opened it.

"The Demonic Realm was created by a demon known as the Red Tyrant, who was one of the most powerful demons back in the Primordial Era."

"After creating this Demonic Realm, the Red Tyrant made it his base, and it would quickly grow into a home for millions of demons."

"Eventually, this Red Tyrant would be known as the Demon God, who ruled over all demons and even humans to a certain extent for thousands of years."

After learning about the Demonic Realm and the Red Tyrant, Yuan asked, "I heard multiple times that demons used to rule the Nine Heavens. What happened back then? How did demons even come into existence?"

"Nobody really knows how demons came into existence, but there is a legend about the first demon appearing from a massive void that suddenly opened up in the starry sky."

"A void in the starry sky...?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"There are also rumors that this demon was the Red Tyrant, hence why he was so powerful, as he is the first demon. Once this demon showed up, almost like ghosts, demons began appearing around the Nine Heavens, terrorizing the people there."

"Since nobody knew about demons and how to defeat them, these demons quickly conquered the Nine Heavens with ease. Once that happened,

humans were enslaved and became nothing more than playthings and food for these demons."

"The demons drank their blood, consumed their meat, chewed their bones—all sorts of horrifying things. Fortunately, almost as though the heavens sent him during the Nine Heavens' darkest times, a certain individual created techniques that allow cultivators to finally fight back the demons, and that person was the Divine Paragon, Founder of the Demon Sealing Clan."

"Although times have changed and it may not seem like it anymore, the Divine Paragon was more than just a hero to many people—he was a savior and god that saved the Nine Heavens."

"I see..." Yuan mumbled in a dazed voice.

'I have underestimated the Divine Paragon... He's much more important and exalted than I'd expected...' He sighed inwardly.

He knew the Divine Paragon was someone important, but he didn't think the Divine Paragon was such a bigshot in the Divine Heavens.

Meanwhile, somewhere in the Fifth Heaven, the sky turned black, and a gaping hole appeared in the sky above the Fairy Paradise, shocking everybody there.

Eventually, the people in the Fairy Paradise noticed a figure had appeared from the hole, and they watched as this figure slowly descended.

Once this person had descended enough, the people in the Fairy Paradise could finally see this figure's appearance, and he was an old man with this unfathomable aura surrounding him.

"The Master's presence lingers in this place..." The old man mumbled in a profound voice as he stared at the Fairy Paradise beneath him.

Chapter 762 - Immortal

"Fairy Empress! We have an emergency!" A woman came running into the Fairy Empress' room shortly after the gaping hole appeared above the Fairy Paradise.

"Calm down, I am aware." Fairy Empress said.

However, despite her calm voice, her face had a huge frown on it, and she was anything but calm.

'What is this feeling? I feel an overwhelming presence coming from the hole... I have never experienced anything like this before...'

The Fairy Empress could feel her entire body shivering from fear when she felt this divine presence.

"All of you stay alert. I am going to see what's happening."

"That's too dangerous! You must stay here, Fairy Empress!"

"Then do you want to go out there and investigate the hole for me?" The Fairy Empress narrowed her eyes at the woman, who immediately closed her mouth and lowered her head, her answer clear.

"I thought so." Fairy Empress coldly sneered before flying out the window to approach the hole.

However, just as she got close to the sky, she noticed a figure descending from this hole, and she immediately recognized that the divine presence she had been feeling this entire time was caused by this figure.

'An Immortal! He's a true Immortal!' Fairy Empress cried inwardly as she realized his identity.

Even though it was a guess, she had no doubt that this old man was an Immortal that had reached an unfathomable level in the cultivation path.

The Fairy Empress wanted to go up to the Immortal and greet him, but she was also afraid to disturb him at the same time.

Therefore, she could only hover in the sky and silently ponder whether she should approach him or not.

While the Fairy Empress pondered, she suddenly felt a presence behind her, causing her to turn around.

"Fuck!"

The Fairy Empress cursed out loud when she was startled by the old man hovering behind her.

'When did he appear behind me?! I didn't see him move at all, nor did I feel his presence until he allowed me to sense it!' The Fairy Empress cried inwardly, as she has never been snuck up on like this before.

Despite her shock, the Fairy Empress straightened her back before bowing to the old man.

"This Junior greets Senior."

The old man looked at her with a nonchalant gaze as he spoke, "I am looking for a certain individual."

"Do you have any descriptions of this person?" Fairy Empress asked.

"I do not."

Although she was a little baffled, the Fairy Empress didn't change her expression and continued to ask, "Then do you know how we can find this person?"

"I do not." The old man repeated.

This left the Fairy Empress speechless. How are they supposed to find someone without any information?

'Is he messing with me?' The Fairy Empress wondered inwardly.

"No, I am not messing with you." The old man suddenly said.

"Eh?"

The Fairy Empress was dumbfounded when he heard the old man's response, and she thought for a second that she had accidentally spoken out loud just now.

"P-Please forgive this Junior!" She quickly apologized to him while thinking to herself, 'Did he just read my mind...?'

And to her absolute surprise, the old man responded once again, "No, I did not read your mind."

'He's definitely reading my mind!'

Once she realized this, Fairy Empress immediately cleared her mind and tried her best to not think about anything.

"Anyways, while I do not have any description about this person, he should be very easy to find." The old man said.

Fairy Empress nodded and paid close attention to his next words.

"This person... He's very talented."

'He's definitely messing with me!' The Fairy Empress cried inwardly.

However, the old man said, "I know you think I am messing with you, but I am not. This person, he's not your average genius. He's a once-in-a-lifetime genius."

"Also, he was only in this place for a brief moment not long ago. His surname should also be 'Tian'."

"Not long ago?" Fairy Empress raised her eyebrows, and a certain individual appeared in her head.

'D-Don't tell me he's looking for the missing Dragon Emperor...?'

Fairy Empress swallowed nervously when she recalled that the old man could read her mind.

But to her surprise, he didn't say anything this time.

"Do you have someone in mind?" The old man noticed her expression and asked her.

"Are you talking about the Dragon Emperor, by any chance? He appeared out of the blue a while ago and vanished just as suddenly. We're also looking for him."

"Dragon Emperor? Tell me more about him." The old man quickly said.

The Fairy Empress nodded and began telling the old man about the Dragon Emperor without giving him all of the details, such as detaining him like a prisoner, as she was afraid that might offend this old man.

"He called himself 'Yuan', and he told us that he'd come to the Fifth Heaven by accident through a teleport formation. The Royal Dragon Family took him to their household, but he disappeared shortly after."

"The Royal Dragon Family..." The old man suddenly turned to look in a certain direction.

The next moment, the Fairy Empress watched as the old man disappeared in front of her like a ghost. She looked around, and once she was certain that he was gone, she released a relieved sigh before flying back to her palace.

As for the old man, he went to give the Royal Dragon Family a visit.

"I can sense his presence here as well... Did he really reincarnate into a Dragon Emperor? No... That shouldn't be possible..." The old man mumbled to himself in a puzzled manner.

The old man stopped pondering to himself and went inside the Dragon Royal Family's household without knocking on the door.

A moment later, he appeared inside the Dragon King's room.

Once inside the room, the old man walked to the bed, where the Dragon King was resting.

The old man stared at the Dragon King's sleeping face for a moment before releasing a hint of killing intent.

"Motherfucker!" The Dragon King jumped out of his bed the instant he sensed the killing intent that nearly gave him a heart attack.

Of course, a hint of killing intent coming from an Immortal would be more than enough to startle even a Spirit Emperor to death.

Chapter 763 - Heavens Mandate

After springing up from his bed, the Dragon King looked around in a confused look.

"W-What in the heavens' name was that killing intent just now?"

The Dragon King was left puzzled when there was nobody in his room.

"Did I have a nightmare because of my stress? I haven't been able to sleep properly since the Dragon Emperor disappeared, after all..." The Dragon King released a deep sigh.

However, just as the Dragon King laid back down on the bed, he heard a voice resound inside his room, and the voice sounded like it was responding to him.

"No, you're not dreaming."

The Dragon King's eyes snapped wide open, and that's when he saw the old man standing beside his bed.

"Fuck! It's a ghost!" The Dragon King screamed for his life.

"Ghost? Can a ghost do this?" The old man suddenly released this divine aura that even though the Dragon King has never experienced before, he instinctively as a cultivator knew that this aura belonged to an immortal.

"I-I-Immortal?!"

The Dragon King was even more shocked to learn that he had been woken up by an Immortal than a ghost!

"I am looking for someone. Can you tell me more about this Dragon Emperor that you took to your household not long ago?"

"T-The Dragon Emperor?"

It took awhile for the Dragon King to process the situation, but when he eventually did, he immediately kowtowed on the bed and apologized, "I'm sorry! The Dragon Emperor had disappeared in my home! We have been searching for him nonstop since his disappearance, but we haven't had any luck!"

The Dragon King mistook the old man as someone the Royal Dragon Family had sent because the Dragon Emperor hasn't returned to his original home.

"Tell me, why do you call him the 'Dragon Emperor'? And what does he look like?" The old man asked the Dragon King even though he already asked the Fairy Empress, as he wanted to confirm the information.

"Why? He was wearing an authentic pair of Golden Dragon Robes, he had a Dragon Spatial Ring, and he can even use Dragon's Gaze!" The Dragon King responded.

And he continued, "As for his appearance, he was a young man with long black hair and brown eyes. His face also looked pure and kind."

The old man silently pondered, 'They say he's a Dragon Emperor, but that's only because of his treasures. It doesn't really prove that he's a Dragon Emperor. Anybody can acquire the Golden Dragon Robe and the Dragon Spatial Ring in the upper heavens if they really try. As for his Dragon's Gaze... The Master and the Dragon Ancestor were like brothers, it wouldn't be weird at all if the Dragon Ancestor taught him Dragon's Gaze.'

"You said this Dragon Emperor suddenly disappeared, is that correct?"

"Yes, that is correct. I left him in one of our guest rooms to rest, and when I went to check on him later, he was already gone."

"And you have no idea where he could have gone?"

"Unfortunately. We have searched everywhere, but we couldn't find him, almost as though he never existed in the first place—"

The Dragon King stopped talking when he suddenly realized the old man had disappeared.

"Eh?"

The Dragon King looked around the room, and to make sure the old man wasn't hiding somewhere to startle him again, he walked around the room, even checking his closets.

"He's really gone... Or maybe he was never here in the first place? Was I hallucinating this entire time? Fuck. I really need some rest..." The Dragon King shook his head and went back to bed, quickly falling asleep.

Meanwhile, the old man hovered above the Dragon Royal Family without alerting a single soul there.

"As expected of the Master, you're a hard one to find. I thought it would be easier this time, but alas..."

"I would like to investigate a little more, but I am out of time. It won't be long before they arrive."

The old man shook his head and disappeared from the Fifth Heavens the next moment, almost as though he'd never existed.

An hour after the old man disappeared from the Fifth Heaven, the sky suddenly turned golden, and the world became illuminated by this holy light.

A massive hole appeared in the sky once again, but it was much larger than the previous.

The people of the Fifth Heaven were shocked by this scene, but what they witnessed next was completely out of their expectations.

"F-Fairy Empress! Look! There's so many people descending from the hole in the sky!"

"My eyes are working just fine!" The Fairy Empress frowned at the scene.

In the sky, a thousand figures wearing silver armor and standing in a formation appeared from the gaping hole, and they all emitted a heavenly aura that made people subconsciously revere them.

There was also a person in front of these soldiers, who was clearly leading this thousand-strong army.

This person was holding onto a large flag that had the words 'Heaven's Mandate' on it, and when people saw this flag, they all got onto their knees and lowered their heads, almost as though they were afraid to confront this flag.

"Heaven's Mandate...? What in heavens' name is the Celestial Emperor's army doing in the Fifth Heaven...?" The Fairy Empress muttered to herself in a low voice after she recognized the flag.

Even though this is her first time seeing these people, she knew who they were and what they represented at glance. In fact, this was the case for everyone in the Fifth Heaven.

And as the Lord of the Fifth Heaven, the Fairy Empress was obligated to greet them, and that's exactly what she did after preparing herself.

"Greetings, Heaven's Mandate. I am the Lord of the Fifth Heaven, Fairy Empress." She bowed to them in a respectful manner.

The man leading the army approached her and spoke in a cold voice, "I am General Li, and I am in charge of the 3rd squad of the Heaven's Mandate. We have been tasked with capturing a dangerous criminal by the Celestial Emperor himself, and we have sensed his presence in this world not long ago."

"Dangerous criminal?" The Fairy Empress raised her eyebrows, and for whatever reason, the old man appeared in her mind.

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Chapter 764 - Stolen Memories

"You seem to know something." General Li said when he noticed the Fairy Empress' expression.

"You see, a gaping hole appeared in the sky above the Fairy Paradise that's right beneath us about an hour before your arrival, and an old man with an unfathomable aura descended from it—"

Before the Fairy Empress could even finish her sentence, General Li exclaimed, "That's him! What did you two speak about?!"

"N-Nothing much. He was looking for a certain individual, but he couldn't give any description or information about this individual. However, he did give me a surname— Tian."

The Fairy Empress noticed General Li's face twisting with fear after hearing her words, and she wondered what this was all about.

"T-T-This 'Tian' individual... Have you seen him?" General Li asked her after a moment of silence.

"I don't know. I did tell the old man about a certain individual I came across not long ago, and the old man appeared to be interested in him." Fairy Empress said.

"Who?! Tell me everything you know about this person! There is only one person in the Nine Heavens that would make that old man come out of his hiding so blatantly! He must have sensed this person's presence here!"

The Fairy Empress quickly opened her mouth to respond, but she didn't utter a single word even many moments later.

General Li raised his eyebrows in a puzzled manner, "What's the matter, Fairy Empress?"

However, the Fairy Empress was just as puzzled as General Li.

"I-I don't know... I can't remember for some reason..." Fairy Empress responded in a dumbfounded voice.

"I know I have met this person before, but I cannot remember his face or our conversations... It's almost as though it had been wiped from my memories..." Fairy Empress continued to explain her phenomenon.

"..."

Despite Fairy Empress' crazy talk, General Li did not seem to be angry at her. In fact, he had a look of understanding on his face.

"You just had your memories stolen by the old man." General Li said, shocking the Fairy Empress.

"W-What do you mean I had my memories 'stolen'?" She asked.

"The old man has a forbidden technique that can steal one's memories. He usually surprises his victims before taking away their memories, as that makes it easier for him to steal your memories." General Li explained to him.

Fairy Empress' eyes widened with surprise upon learning about this information. Is this why the old man scared her by appearing behind her like a ghost?

'He did that to steal my memories? But I didn't even realize my memories had been stolen, and I probably would've never realized it if General Li never told me...'

"Why did he not steal my memories of him? Wouldn't that be more logical?" Fairy Empress asked a moment later.

"Because he's arrogant like that. He is aware that we've been chasing him, and he purposefully allowed us to chase him. The reason he left your memories of him is so that we could confirm his presence had been here."

After pondering for a bit, Fairy Empress spoke, "Even though he'd stolen my memories, there are other people that have seen this person he's looking for!"

However, General Li shook his head and said, "That won't work. The moment the old man stole your memories, he would know everyone that's involved and steal their memories as well. Although I am confident that's the case, we will still investigate just in case he'd slip up. After all, it's been thousands of years since he last showed up."

Fairy Empress swallowed nervously.

She then led General Li and his people to see those who had met with Yuan before. Even though her memories had been stolen, it was only her memories of meeting and speaking with Yuan.

Sometime later, General Li met with Elder Xue and the disciples that had met with Yuan before.

Of course, the ladies were surprised to see so many men inside the Fairy Paradise. However, it was not as though the Fairy Empress could do anything about the situation, as these people were working directly for the Celestial Emperor, the most powerful individual in the Nine Heavens.

"Have you seen an old man recently?" Fairy Empress asked them.

And to her surprise, all of them nodded their heads.

"I thought I was only seeing things. The old man appeared behind me like a ghost while I was working inside my room, but when I blinked, he was gone." Elder Xue said.

"That happened to me as well! I was taking a bath in the lake when I noticed an old man staring at me from behind the trees. I was terrified at

that time, but when I looked again, he had vanished like a ghost!"

Everybody there recalled their experience with the creepy old man who was appearing and vanishing like a real ghost.

General Li wasn't surprised, but just in case, he asked them about their encounter with Yuan.

In the end, none of them could remember Yuan's face or their conversations with him, but they could remember their encounter with him.

Sometime later, General Li said to the Fairy Empress, "If he ever shows up again or you remember something about this 'Tian', use this jade slip to contact me."

General Li and his thousand-strong army departed the Fairy Paradise and went to the Royal Dragon Family.

Inside the royal guest room, the Dragon King sat before General Li with a profound frown on his face.

"I cannot remember this person's face or name, but I do recall his identity as a Dragon Emperor." The Dragon King said.

"Dragon Emperor?" General Li raised his eyebrows.

"Yes, the old man asked me about the Dragon Emperor. I remember taking the Dragon Emperor to our home, but he disappeared shortly after. That's the extent of my memories." The Dragon King sighed.

And he asked General Li, "If you don't mind me asking, why are you looking for this old man? I thought he was only a hallucination of mine because of my lack of sleep."

After a moment of silence, General Li spoke in a solemn voice, "The day the old man reunites with 'Tian', the Nine Heavens will erupt with chaos.. That's all I can say since that's all I know."

Chapter 765 - Within The Seventh Heaven

"The Nine Heavens will erupt with chaos...? That sounds like a calamity I don't want to experience..." The Dragon King muttered in a dazed voice.

He could've never imagined how serious the situation was, and he couldn't fathom how an old man meeting with someone could possibly start a calamity in the Nine Heavens.

"Anyways, I will speak with everyone that has encountered this person the old man wiped from their memories just in case they remember." General Li said to the Dragon King.

The Dragon King nodded his head and proceeded to send everyone that had encountered Yuan to speak with General Li.

In the end, all of them had their memories stolen from them.

"That old man stole our memories? How is that even possible? He never even got close to me!"

The victims were in disbelief after learning about it.

"The old man possesses an ancient technique that allows him to steal your memories. Although it loses its effects in the upper heavens, this technique works flawlessly against cultivators with inferior cultivation."

"Anyways, I have spent enough time here. I must return and report my findings to the Celestial Emperor."

General Li left the Royal Dragon Family's household shortly after and returned to the upper heavens with the rest of the Heaven's Mandate.

Meanwhile, somewhere in the upper heavens, the old man returned to the jade tablet and sighed, "After looking at their memories of you, I am reminded of your brilliance during your prime days."

"Oh, how I wish I could watch you grow this time as well..."

"But alas, it seems like fate is trying its hardest to keep me away from you. This must be those bastards' doing."

"Unfortunately for them, not even fate can hold you down now. It will only be a matter of time before you return to us and seize the heaven that you rightfully own."

The old man lowered his body until he was on his knees, and he kowtowed to the jade tablet in a revering manner, almost as though he was praying to his god.

While all of this was happening, Yuan was listening to Yan Hara talk about the Demonic Realm.

"And soon after the Divine Paragon sealed off the Demonic Realm, pretty much everyone had forgotten about it, as it was no longer of their concern. Any questions?" Yan Hara asked him.

"Just one." Yuan nodded, and he continued to ask, "Where is the Demonic Realm right now?"

"Where?" Yan Hara raised her eyebrows, wondering to herself why he wanted to know such information, as it sounded like he wanted to go there.

"It's located in the Seventh Heaven, and it's heavily guarded by the Demon Sealing Clan and the Demon Sealing Grotto to make sure nobody messes with the seal. Why do you want to know? Do you want to visit the place?" Yan Hara had to ask him.

Yuan didn't lie and confirmed her suspicions, "Yes, I am a little interested in the Demonic Realm, and I was wondering if I could take a look at it."

"Unfortunately, only those at the top of the Demon Sealing Clan are allowed to get close to the Demonic Realm. Anybody that tries to get close without permission, regardless of their identity, will be slain. The Demon Sealing Clan takes the safety of the seal extremely seriously, after all."

"If you really want to visit the place, you will need to increase your influence within the Demon Sealing Clan. If you become the founder, you can go anywhere you want." Yan Hara said with a suggestive smile on her face.

"You really want me to become the founder, huh?" Yuan couldn't help but smile at her stubbornness.

"If you become the founder, it will almost be like the Divine Paragon has returned— like living a historical event."

"I will think about it." Yuan sighed.

"Please do." Yan Hara chuckled.

Sometime later, Yuan asked Yan Hara, "Now that I am an Advanced Demon Sealer, can I take a look at the demon sealing techniques?"

"Sure thing. Follow me." Yan Hara stood up and brought Yuan to another room, where twelve jade tablets existed.

Yuan immediately began looking through the tablets, and he realized that he recognized a couple of these techniques from his memories.

As the creator of these techniques, he should recognize all of these techniques, but he only recovered a small portion of his memories, hence his situation.

"I'm going to spend a few days here if you don't mind." Yuan turned to look at Yan Hara.

"You can stay here for as long as you'd like. If you have any questions, I will always be here." Yan Hara said.

She then retrieved a jade slip from her spatial ring before handing it to him.

"This is my communication jade slip. Use this to contact me whenever you're in the Grand Library and have any questions."

"Thank you." Yuan accepted the jade slip.

"Then I will leave you alone for now." Yan Hara said to him before leaving the place.

Once he was left alone, Yuan sat before one of the jade tablets and began trying to comprehend the technique.

While Yuan focused on the jade tablets, the other cultivators there would watch him from a distance.

"Isn't he the rumored 'little founder'?"

"I think so. He looks so much like the Divine Paragon's statue."

"I thought it was a hoax, but now that I am seeing him with my own eyes, I feel a little foolish."

The people in the room wanted to approach Yuan out of curiosity, but seeing how he was focused on the jade tablet, nobody bothered him.

"I heard he accepted Senior Yan as his lecturer? What a lucky one. Many people want to be taught by her, but she always refuses them. I think he is her first student."

"I would be surprised if she didn't accept him.. Didn't you know that she's a huge Divine Paragon fanatic? Rumor has it that she's even part of some cult that treats the Divine Paragon as their god."

Chapter 766 - Divine Paragon Fanatics

A couple of days have passed since Yuan started studying the Divine-rank demon sealing techniques, and he has managed to learn all 12 techniques in this short time.

'It's almost time for me to visit the Qi Family. Thankfully, I managed to learn all of these techniques before then.' Yuan thought to himself as he prepared to leave.

However, right as he prepared to log off, Yan Hara showed up in the room and said to him, "Little founder! I want you to meet a few of my friends!"

"Huh?"

Yuan turned to look at the entrance, and to his surprise, there was a small group of beautiful women being led by Yan Hara.

The moment these beautiful women laid their eyes on Yuan, they began screaming—the excitement type of scream.

"Whaaa! It's really him! I am having a hard time believing it even though he's standing right there!"

"Heavens! He really looks like the Divine Paragon!"

"I thought you were exaggerating, but alas! I'm sorry for doubting you, Senior Sister!"

The group of women quickly surrounded Yuan and even started touching him as though he was a doll.

"H-Hey! I told you girls that you cannot touch him!" Yan Hara quickly intervened.

"Sorry, little founder. These girls are all big fans of the Divine Paragon, and they begged me to take them to you after they heard the rumors."

"It's alright." Yuan said with a stiff smile on his face. He wasn't unfamiliar with being idolized. In fact, he has been in even more crowded situations.

"Excuse me, little founder! Can I take a picture of you?" One of the ladies there suddenly asked him.

"Huh? A picture?" Yuan raised his eyebrows. He wondered how taking pictures work in this world.

"I will give you this treasure as a compensation!" The woman then showed him a beautiful necklace that radiated with a profound aura.

"Whoa! Are you seriously going to trade that treasure for a picture, Junior Sister?"

Yuan silently stared at the necklace for a moment before shaking his head.

"It's fine, I don't need the treasure. It's just a picture, right? I will do it for free." Yuan said to her.

"Really?! Thank you! Really! Thank you, little founder!" The woman was ecstatic by the results.

"Please, follow me!" The woman said to him.

Yuan nodded and followed her to the area with the Divine Paragon's statue.

"Can you stand beside the statue and look in my direction?"

"Sure."

Once Yuan was standing beside the statue, the woman said, "Now can you do this pose?"

Seeing her pose, Yuan placed his arms behind his back like a scholar.

"Great! Now give me the best smile you've got!"

Yuan pondered for a moment before putting a gentle smile on his face.

"T-That's perfect! Now stay like that for a few minutes!"

The woman suddenly retrieved a large piece of blank paper and a brush, and she quickly began drawing on the piece of paper while staring at Yuan the entire time.

'This is what she meant by 'taking a picture'?' Yuan was dumbfounded by the results. He could've never predicted that she would start drawing him on the spot with a brush.

About fifteen minutes later, the woman finally stopped looking at Yuan to look at the result of her art.

"Perfect!" The woman exclaimed in a trembling voice.

She then turned the paper around to show Yuan her work, and to his absolute surprise, the art looked incredibly surreal, almost as though he was actually living inside the painting!

"What do you think?" She asked him.

"I-I'm speechless. I have never seen such a beautiful painting before, and it only took you a few minutes to draw such a masterpiece!" Yuan couldn't fathom it.

The woman didn't change her brush during the entire process, so he expected the painting to be black and white, but when he saw the painting, it was vivid with colors!

"You may not believe it, but she's actually a really famous painter within the Nine Heavens." Yan Hara said to him.

"There are many people out there that wish to be painted by her, and it would usually cost them an arm and leg." Yan Hara chuckled. This is actually her first time seeing this woman willing to draw someone for free! In fact, she even wanted to pay to paint him!

"Anyways, I demand a copy of that painting, Sister Sun. I am the reason you got that painting today, after all."

Sister Sun nodded and said, "Don't worry, I will make a copy for everyone in the family."

"Family? You're siblings?" Yuan asked.

"Not that kind of family." Yan Hara showed him a mysterious smile.

Seeing her weird smile, Yuan figured that it would be for the best if he didn't ask about it.

"Little founder, here." Sister Sun suddenly extended her hand to him.

Yuan looked at the necklace in her hand and shook his head, "I already said I don't need any payment."

"I know. This is not a payment. This is a gift to celebrate our encounter. That's all."

Although Yuan was still reluctant to accept such a precious-looking treasure, he had to accept it when Sister Sun basically forced it into his hands.

"Thank you..." Yuan said to her afterward.

Sometime later, Yuan said to Yan Hara, "Senior, I will be away for a while. I don't know when I will return to this place."

"That's completely fine, but try to show up a month from now. There will be a competition amongst demon sealers. I will tell you more about it when the time comes."

"Okay. A month, right? I will be here."

After speaking with the ladies for a couple more minutes, Yuan logged off Cultivation Online and began his preparations for his trip to the Qi Family.

Near the end of the day, the Manager showed up to his house to notify him that they will be leaving tomorrow.

"Meet me in the front at sunrise." She said to him.

"I understand.." Yuan acknowledged.

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Chapter 767 - Fearing For His Life

"By the way, how long will I be staying with the Qi Family?" Yuan asked the Manager before she left.

"You can leave whenever you want," she said to him as she walked away.

That night, Chu Liuxiang asked him, "You'll be visiting my Master's family tomorrow, right? Can I come with you?"

"The Mountain Lord said that I should go alone since the Qi Family doesn't like guests." Yuan said.

"I see... How long will you be gone for?"

"I'm not sure, but I will try to come back as soon as possible."

"Stay safe out there."

"The only one I need to be wary of is your master. I hope she doesn't hold a grudge after because I left her sealed." Yuan sighed.

"Master may be arrogant and a little hot-headed, she's not an unreasonable person. If you speak with her, I'm sure she'll forgive you."

"I hope so."

"Good night, darling."

"Good night."

The following morning, Yuan met up with the Manager, who was waiting at the front of his building in a luxurious red car.

"Get in the back," she said to him.

Once Yuan was in the car, the Manager took off and began driving down the mountain.

However, the speed she was descending the mountain at was a little unnatural—unnaturally fast.

Yuan quickly realized that the Manager was a reckless driver who would drift at even the slightest curve in the road, and she was basically speeding down the mountain at a ridiculous speed.

Yuan has never really feared for his life outside of Cultivation Online, but riding in the same car as the Manager made him feel insecure about his safety, and he worried that they might die at any moment.

Once they left the Dragon Spiral Mountain, Yuan expected the Manager to slow down, but alas, she only sped up.

"S-Shouldn't you slow down a little?" Yuan could no longer stay silent and said to her.

"Why?" The Manager said, dumbfounding him.

"Why...? It's dangerous to be going this fast, not to mention illegal..."

"We'll be fine." The Manager said in a nonchalant manner before increasing the speed by ten more miles.

By now, they were going at least 140 miles per hour, and Yuan was prepared to jump out of the car at any moment.

After a few minutes of this madness, Yuan could hear the sound of police sirens blaring from behind them.

However, instead of stopping for the police, the Manager actually increased the speed!

'She's crazy!' Yuan cried inwardly. He never expected the Manager to be such a lunatic, and he swore to himself that he would never sit in a car with her ever again as long as she was behind the wheels.

The police sirens only got louder as more and more police cars appeared behind them, yet the car continued to zoom forward.

Eventually, they arrived at a spacious lot that had a dozen airplanes and even private jets stationed.

Once they arrived before a specific red jet, the Manager finally stopped the car.

The moment their car stopped, the police cars that had been chasing them immediately surrounded the car.

"Get out of the vehicle with your hands up!" One of the policemen shouted with a megaphone right in front of his mouth.

"What now?" Yuan asked.

The Manager didn't respond to him and took out her own megaphone before speaking into it with a tranquil voice, "Why don't you idiots run the license already and get out of my way?"

When the police heard her words, they immediately ran her car's license plate through their system.

Once the results came in, the entire place turned dead silent.

Yuan could see the police mumbling to each other, but he couldn't hear their words.

A few minutes later, the policeman with the megaphone spoke again, but he sounded more respectful this time, "There has been a misunderstanding. Please forgive us. We'll leave you alone right now."

"W-What?" Yuan was baffled by the polices' confusing response.

He thought they were only playing along for the heck of it, but sure enough, the police returned to their cars before driving away as though nothing had happened.

"This is the influence of the Dragon Spiral Mountain, and as long as you live within the mountain, you represent us. Never forget this." The Manager suddenly said to him.

"You caused all of this chaos just to prove this point?" Yuan was utterly speechless.

"No, this is how I normally drive."

The Manager then got out of the car and said to him, "Let's go."

Yuan immediately frowned when he saw the Manager walking towards the jet before them.

"Don't tell me you're going to drive this plane as well?" He asked her while silently hoping that was not the case.

"No, I am not."

Yuan sighed a breath of relief after hearing her words, but he almost choked on air after hearing her next sentence.

"You're going to be the one driving it."

"You want a blind man with no experience to drive a plane? Is this some kind of punishment you're giving me because of what I did to the Chu Family?" Yuan had a feeling that she was making things difficult for him on purpose as a way to punish him.

"I have no idea what you're talking about. As for driving the plane, even a 10-year-old can do it. Hurry up and get on the plane already. We're going to be late at this rate." The Manager said as she entered the plane.

"What about your car?"

"Just leave it there. Somebody will take care of it later," she said.

Once they were both inside the plane, the Manager shut the door and led him to the cockpit.

She pointed at the obvious red button and said, "Just press that button and the plane will enter auto-pilot. I am going to sleep, so you're going to watch the plane. Don't press anything else unless you want to crash the plane."

And without explaining anything else, the Manager went to one of the rooms in the back to sleep, leaving Yuan alone and dumbfounded in the cockpit.

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Chapter 768 - Qi Family

After staring at the red button for a few minutes, Yuan eventually gave up and pressed it, his fingers trembling while doing so.

Immediately after pressing the button, the plane began to move, and Yuan watched as the plane turned towards the flight path and started moving without needing him to do anything.

A few moments later, they were in the air.

Seeing that they were flying without any problems, Yuan released a sigh of relief, but even then, he could not leave the cockpit unattended, so he sat in one of the two chairs and proceeded to just enjoy the scenery with his divine sense.

Of course, since he was using divine sense, he was able to see the Manager sleeping peacefully inside her room.

"She really went to sleep..." He thought she was only saying that to mess with him, but turns out she was telling the truth.

And while he sat in the cockpit, Yuan would use this time to continue trying to learn Technique Transmission.

Eight hours later, Yuan noticed the plane tilting downwards.

"It's descending? This should mean we're close to the Qi Family."

Half an hour later, the plane landed itself on a medium-sized island surrounded by water.

"The Qi Family really lives on an island..."

Sometime later, Yuan left the cockpit and went to knock on the Manager's door.

"Manager, we have arrived."

However, the Manager remained sleeping inside.

Yuan knocked on the door a couple more times before going into her room and shaking her awake.

"Manager! Wake up! We have landed!"

"Huh?"

The Manager sat up on the bed with a drowsy expression and saliva drooling from her mouth.

She stared at Yuan for a moment before snapping out of her daze and shouting with a flushed face, "G-Get out! I will be with you later!"

"Alright." Yuan said with a smile on his face, which only made the Manager's face flush even more.

After leaving the plane, Yuan waited for the Manager, who showed up five minutes later with a cold expression on her face, and she looked more angry than normal.

"Follow me," she said as she walked ahead.

Meanwhile, a few miles ahead, the Qi Family was preparing for the meeting.

"Qi Fang, come with us. There's going to be a meeting with the Manager of the Dragon Spiral Mountain soon. Apparently, the Lord wants us to work with someone to deal with the demons in the mountain." An old man said to a beautiful woman when he encountered her in the hallways.

"Okay." Qi Fang nodded, and she followed him into the meeting room.

Once they were seated, Qi Fang said, "I know the 11 demons within the Dragon Spiral Mountain is a calamity waiting to happen, but we should deal with our own problem before we help others."

"I know what you're thinking, but we're also receiving help from him. This person they're sending here— he will assist us with our problem."

"Who is this person, anyway?"

"The Lord didn't give any specifics, but he did guarantee us that he's very experienced with demons."

"Experienced with demons?" Qi Fang frowned upon hearing this.

'I swear to god, if it's that bastard...'

Meanwhile, after walking for about half an hour, Yuan and the Manager arrived before the Qi Family's household.

Once they were at the front gate, the Manager rang the bell and waited for a response.

A few moments later, a middle-aged woman wearing traditional clothing showed up to open the gate.

"Welcome to the Qi Family, Manager. The elders are expecting your presence in the meeting room."

The Manager and Yuan entered the estate and followed the middle-aged woman to a medium-sized building shaped like a pavilion beside the main household.

The middle-aged woman knocked on the door and said out loud, "Elders, the Manager and her friend have arrived."

"Let them in!" A voice quickly responded.

The middle-aged woman opened the door and gestured for them to enter.

Once they entered the building, Yuan immediately felt an unpleasant gaze directed at him, and when he looked at this person giving him the glares, it was a familiar face.

Sure enough, it was Senior Qi, who was also known as Qi Fang.

"Welcome, Manager and little friend." An old man stood up and greeted them with clasped hands.

Yuan returned his greetings and said, "Good morning, my name is Yuan."

"Yuan? The one who assisted the Six Spiritual Families in subjugating the demon? I heard about you. I didn't think you would be the one coming here today." The old woman sitting beside the old man said.

"By the way, I am Qi Huan," she added.

"I'm Qi Man, retired patriarch of the Qi Family." The old man said.

"Qi Fang..." Senior Qi said in a low voice.

"Hm? What's the matter, Qi'er? Why do you have a frown on your face?" Qi Man asked her.

"It's nothing." Qi Fang stopped frowning the next moment.

Nobody in the Qi Family was aware of her fight with Yuan, as it was too embarrassing for her to admit that she'd lost to a junior like him.

"Anyways, have a seat." Qi Huan pointed at the chairs.

Once they sat down, the Manager said, "As the Lord has promised, Yuan will help you with your problem. In return, you will help us with our problem."

"Of course. If he can really assist us, we will spare no effort dealing with your demons."

"Huh? You never told me anything about helping them." Yuan suddenly said.

"You didn't?" The Qi Family turned to look at the Manager with raised eyebrows.

"I forgot," said the Manager in a calm voice.

She then turned to look at Yuan and continued, "You will be helping them kill a demon."

"What?!" Yuan exclaimed.

He thought he came here to make friends with the Qi Family, not kill demons for them! Furthermore, why would they need his help when they are all demon sealers themselves? It made no sense!

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Chapter 769 - Entering Seclusion

"W-Wait a second! Why do you need my help killing a demon? Aren't you guys a demon sealing clan? If you need my help killing your demon, how will you help us with our 11 demons?!" Yuan asked them what was on his mind.

"I understand your confusion, so allow me to explain it to you." Qi Man said.

And he continued, "Although we are indeed a family that has dedicated itself to dealing with demons since ancient times, we do not actually have the capability to kill demons, only prolong their seal."

"There is a powerful demon that is currently sealed on this island, but its seal is getting weaker. We have been resealing this demon since ancient times, and it has gotten to the point where our techniques are no longer effective on it, so it will eventually break out of its seal and kill us all, and it is only a matter of time before it happens."

"We heard rumors that the Six Spiritual Families had managed to kill a demon, but we do not entirely believe such a rumor. After all, the Six Spiritual Families do not have the capability to seal demons, much less kill them."

"Since you were there, can you enlighten us on how such a thing happened? We tried asking them about it, but they refused to tell us the truth."

After a moment of silence, Yuan said, "Because I was the one who killed the demon, and they hid the fact to protect me."

The room immediately fell silent.

Qi Fang already knew this fact, but her grandparents were hearing this information for the first time, so they wore shocked expressions on their faces afterward.

"Y-You killed the demon? H-How?" Qi Man eventually snapped out of his daze to ask.

"Sorry, it's not that I don't want to tell you, I just don't know how to explain it." Yuan shook his head.

The old couples exchanged looks with each other.

After a moment of silence, Qi Man stood up and said, "Follow me. I will show you the demon."

Yuan nodded and followed them outside.

After following this narrow path to an open area, Yuan could see over a dozen people guarding this large tree on a small hill.

When they got close, the guards greeted the old couple.

"Let us through. My friend here would like to see the demon." Qi Man said.

The guards turned to look at Yuan and nodded silently, not that they had any choice.

Once they were on the hill, Qi Man pointed at the tree and said, "There is a demon sealed within this tree. Go around it and you should see it."

Yuan nodded and walked around this tree, and sure enough, he could see a hideous-looking demon with a bulky body coexisting with this tree.

Dong!

The moment Yuan approached this demon, the entire island began shaking.

"It won't be long before this demon breaks out of its seal. This is already the 4th earthquake this month." Qi Huan sighed.

"Do you think you can kill it without breaking it out of its seal?" Qi Man asked him.

"In order to kill a demon, you must separate its core with the body or destroy the demon faster than it can regenerate." Yuan said.

"Since it's sealed, I won't be able to extract its core without breaking it out of the seal. As for the second method... I'm not sure I am capable of killing a demon, but I can try."

"Really? Does this mean you'll help us?" Qi Huan asked him.

"I will help you if you accept one of my conditions."

"What condition?"

"I get to keep its demon core after killing it."

"Demon core?" Qi Man raised his eyebrows.

This is his first time hearing about such a thing.

"If you kill the demon, it's only natural that you get whatever it leaves behind."

"Okay. I will need to prepare first." Yuan said.

"Whatever you need, my Qi Family will supply it."

"I don't need anything, only time and a place where I cannot be disturbed."

After all, he only needed to learn the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike to kill the demon.

"I know the perfect place. Follow me."

Yuan then followed Qi Man back down the hill and onto another path, which led him to a large cave.

"Immortal Caves?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"That's right. This is our Qi Family's immortal caves. The spiritual energy here is the best, and you won't be disturbed by anybody."

"How long do you think you will need to prepare?" Qi Man then asked.

"A week to be safe."

"I understand." Qi Man nodded.

Yuan then turned to the Manager and asked her, "Can you let my friends back at home know about the situation? I don't want them to worry when I don't return even after a week."

The Manager silently nodded.

"Thank you."

Yuan entered one of the available Immortal Caves shortly after and went into seclusion to learn the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike.

Once Yuan went into seclusion, the Qi Family and the Manager returned to the household.

"Do you really think he is capable of killing the demon? He looks too young..." Qi Huan expressed her worries to the Manager.

"..."

After a moment of silence, the Manager said, "I don't know, but the Lord seems to believe in his abilities."

"Well, I think he's a lot more capable than he appears." Qi Fang suddenly said.

The old couple turned to look at her and said, "You have been acting weird all day long. Do you, by any chance, know that boy?"

Qi Fang's eyebrows twitched after hearing their words, and after releasing a deep sigh, she decided to tell them the truth— at least some of it.

"Yes, I know him. We met very briefly at the Chu Family, and we had an exchange with each other.. It was during that time that I experienced for myself a little of what he's capable of, and he's a lot stronger than he looks."

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Chapter 770 - I Will Handle It

After speaking with the Qi Family, the Manager called Meixiu's phone to let her know about the situation.

"Hello?"

"This is the Manager of the Dragon Spiral Mountain. Is this Meixiu's phone number?"

"Yes, this is Meixiu speaking. Did something happen to Yuan?" Meixiu quickly asked about Yuan.

"No, I am just calling to let you know that he will be staying at the Qi Family for a little longer than anticipated."

"..."

"I understand... Can I speak to him?" Meixiu asked after a moment of silence.

"Unfortunately, he's currently in seclusion, so he will not be able to speak with you."

"W-Wait... What do you mean by that? Why is he in seclusion?"

The Manager proceeded to explain the whole situation to Meixiu.

"He's going to fight a demon?!" Meixiu's anxious voice resounded after hearing everything.

"Not exactly. He's going to exterminate a sealed demon."

"How is that any different?" Meixiu frowned.

"Does it really matter? In the end, he agreed to it."

"How long will this take?"

"About a week," said the Manager.

"I understand... I will tell the others. Just make sure he's safe..."

"As much as I hate that idea, it is my job as the Manager of the Dragon Spiral Mountain to keep its residents safe... No matter how much I dislike that resident."

Once the connection stopped, Meixiu went to notify the others about the situation while the Manager and the Qi Family waited for Yuan to emerge from his seclusion.

A week passed by in a flash, and during this time, the island shook three more times.

"Is he coming out of his seclusion anytime soon? It's already been a week, and the demon is showing signs of unsealing." Qi Fang complained as she stood in front of Yuan's immortal cave with the others.

"You know what? I think we should go inside and see what the hell is taking him so long! We don't have any more time!"

Just as Qi Fang began approaching the immortal cave, a figure emerged from the cave entrance.

"Took you long enough! I sincerely hope that you're fully prepared! It's been a week!" Qi Fang said to Yuan, who just finished his seclusion.

"Sorry, it took longer than expected." Yuan said.

Since the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike is actually part of another Divine-rank technique, he had to improve his Heaven's Secret Art first, which is harder than learning even an Ancient-rank technique.

"I am ready to kill the demon. Let's go." Yuan then said.

Sometime later, they arrived at the tree on the hill.

"So... How are you going to exterminate it?" Qi Man asked once they were standing in front of the sealed demon that had cracks appearing all over its body.

"I am going to destroy it using my technique."

"Technique? A demon sealing technique?"

"No, it's a powerful technique that can obliterate everything in its path. I have killed a demon before using this technique." Yuan said.

"Stay back. I don't want anybody to be caught up in the blast."

Once everybody was at a safe distance, Yuan summoned the Empyrean Overlord and started gathering all of the spiritual energy in the air.

"What the heck is he doing...?" Qi Fang mumbled in a low voice.

"I don't know, but whatever he's doing, it's going to be big and powerful..." The Manager said in a dazed voice.

She has never seen such a massive amount of spiritual energy gathered in one spot before.

Yuan took his time gathering as much spiritual energy as he could since he didn't want to take any chances with this bulky demon.

While Yuan gathered his strength, the island began shaking again.

"The demon... It's pulsating with light..." Qi Huan pointed at the demon in the tree that was glowing red in a heartbeat rhythm.

This is the closest they have seen a demon being unsealed, and they were getting goosebumps all over their bodies.

A few minutes later, Yuan was finally finished with charging his strike.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan swung his sword and released all of the spiritual energies that he had gathered, shooting a bright beam of light at the sealed demon.

BOOM!

The beam consumed the entire tree and most of the hill, instantly evaporating it.

This shocked the Qi Family and the Manager, as they have never seen anything this destructive before.

"It's just like a nuclear weapon..." Qi Man mumbled in a dazed voice.

Yuan fell to his knees and began gasping for air after releasing the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike, feeling as though half of his energy had been drained from that one attack.

However, before he could even catch his breath, he suddenly heard Qi Fang's screaming voice, "Yuan! In front of you!"

Yuan immediately used his divine sense to look at the scene before him, and to his absolute shock and horror, there was a glob of red slimy substance on the ground that was moving around as though it was alive.

'I-I didn't manage to kill it? Did I not use enough spiritual energy? No... I used even more than the last time! This demon must be far stronger than the one in the Mystic Realm!'

Yuan turned to look at the Qi Family and shouted at them, "Leave this place immediately! I will handle the demon!"

"A-Are you sure?! We can assist you!" Qi Fang said out loud.

"I am sure! Just leave! I will handle it! Trust me!"

Qi Fang looked at the others and they all nodded at each other before leaving the place to alert the others.

Shortly after the others left, the red substance started forming into a large, bulky figure, and in just a few moments, it'd managed to completely recover, becoming a full demon again.

It silently stared at Yuan with a calm expression for a moment before showing an ugly smile on its face, "That hurt like hell, human.. You're going to pay for waking this Supreme One up in such a rude fashion."

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Chapter 771 - Toying With The Demon

"I thought you demons couldn't feel pain." Yuan said to the demon in a calm voice after hearing its words.

"And calling yourself the 'Supreme One' when you're just a lowly demon that had been sealed for heaven-knows-how-long... You're full of it."

"Oh? You not only dare to speak back to me but also mock me? Since when have humans become so brave?" The grin on the demon's face grew wider, and its bloodlust and aura continued to rise.

'It only has the strength of a Spirit Grandmaster... How did it survive my Heaven Splitting Sword Strike? And it looks slightly different compared to the other demons I have encountered so far.' Yuan wondered to himself.

Furthermore, demons would normally get angry at the slightest provocation, yet this demon managed to remain calm despite Yuan's mockery.

There was just something different about this demon.

The demon looked at its surroundings and asked, "How long have I been sealed? And where am I?"

"You're asking the wrong person. And even if I knew, I wouldn't tell you."

"Is that so? Then I have no reason to keep you alive any longer. I will kill you and find someone else to entertain me, and then I will replenish my strength by eating everyone in this place." The demon stretched its thick neck left and right as it slowly approached Yuan in a menacing manner.

Once it was halfway to Yuan, it suddenly disappeared from its spot.

Yuan quickly raised the Empyrean Overlord in front of him in a defensive manner, and the next second, he was sent flying backward by a powerful strike from the demon.

"You managed to block my strike? Even though my strength has diminished greatly after being sealed for so long, it's still very impressive. This is going to be fun." The bulky demon laughed out loud.

'This demon is strong...' Yuan quickly stabilized himself after being sent flying.

However, he wasn't feeling worried even in the slightest. In fact, he was even a little excited.

'Even though the artificial demons are very useful, they cannot compare to real demons. I'm going to take this chance to practice with a real demon!'

Yuan could've sealed the demon while it was still recovering. However, he purposefully allowed the demon to fully recover just so he could use it as a training puppet.

It was an incredibly selfish and risky thing to do, as it could backfire on him and the Qi Family, but Yuan went ahead and risked it anyway for some reason.

Yuan began approaching the demon and said, "If you don't hurry up and kill me, I will seal you again, and this time, you won't be able to escape ever again."

The bulky demon's muscles began moving around like there were live worms in its body after hearing Yuan's words that had clearly affected it.

"You just gave me another reason to kill you."

The demon suddenly disappeared from its spot again, but it did not escape from Yuan's divine sense.

"Ha!"

Yuan turned around and swung the Empyrean Overlord with incredible force.

The demon that had just appeared behind him subconsciously blocked the strike with its bare arms.

The Empyrean Overlord tore right through the demon's arms and severed them before sending the demon's body flying into the distance.

"Hahaha! Not bad! Not bad at all!" The demon laughed as its body clashed into dozens of trees.

Once it regained its footing, the demon leaped into the air and began throwing spears made out of its blood at Yuan.

"Seal!"

Yuan roared, and a powerful ripple of demon sealing aura swept the scene, instantly halting the blood spears midair and turning them into stone.

Feeling slight stiffness in its body, the demon frowned, and it stopped taking the situation lightly and saw Yuan as a real threat.

Meanwhile, Qi Fang stopped running after a few minutes.

"Why are you stopping?!" Qi Huan asked her.

Qi Fang frowned and said, "This doesn't feel right at all! Why do we have to run like some coward?! We are the Qi Family! I am not going to let him fight the demon alone! I have been training for this day even before I could start walking!"

"You guys can go ahead and go back to the Qi Family, I am going to go help him!"

And without waiting for a response, Qi Fang began running back the way she came from.

"I will go after her." The Manager said to the old couple before chasing after Qi Fang.

"Shit!" Qi Man cursed out loud before turning to look at the guards that guarded the sealed demons before and continued, "Go back and warn the family! We cannot let a guest do our jobs for us!"

"Yes!"

"I will come with you." Qi Huan said to him, and they also started running back to the hill.

However, when they returned to the hill, they were shocked to see the destruction that had ravaged the place.

Most of the trees there were either destroyed or burned, and there were many holes and even ground fissures as far as their eyes could see.

"H-How the hell did they manage to cause such destruction in just a few minutes?!" Qi Fang cried out loud when she saw the scenery.

BOOM!

The earth shook with loud noises that sounded like thunder every few seconds, but it was not an earthquake, and the sky was as clear as it could be.

"They're over there!" Qi Man suddenly pointed to two figures fighting in the distance.

However, when they looked closely, they realized that it was not even a fight at all, but a one-sided beatdown.

"Heavens... He really didn't need our help..." Qi Huan mumbled in a dazed voice as she watched Yuan toss the demon around with his giant sword.

Yuan's attacks were so relentless and fierce that the demon could barely react to them, and when the demon would try to retaliate, he would seal the

demon's body just enough so that it could not move without completely sealing it.

"This bastard... He's toying with the demon!" Qi Fang was in disbelief.

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Chapter 772 - How Will It Taste?

"What in god's name is going on? How is he doing that?" Qi Man mumbled in a voice of disbelief as he watched Yuan throw the demon left and right like some kind of stress toy.

"Do you think he still needs our help?" Qi Huan asked in a sarcastic tone.

Suddenly—

"AAAAAHHHHHHHHHHH!"

The demon released a deafening roar that shook the world.

"How dare a puny human play with me?! I will make you pay! I WILL MAKE YOU PAY!"

The demon's body began growing larger and larger until it was nearly twice its original size, becoming a mini giant.

Yuan had seen this kind of transformation before from the demon at the Jaded Garden, so he knew that he should stop playing around and actually take care of the demon once and for all before he makes a mistake and gets himself and everyone killed.

The demon released another loud roar before summoning two large greatswords with its own blood and wielding it.

It then leaped at Yuan with intense bloodlust radiating from its body.

However, before it could even begin falling back down, the demon felt something pierce its face.

It wasn't painful, but its vision blacked out for a second, and when its vision recovered after the gaping hole in its face was healed, the demon could see that Yuan had suddenly appeared in front of it.

"In the end, you weren't anything too special besides being a decent punching bag." Yuan said to the demon right before extending his empty hand towards the demon's chest and grabbing the red crystal embedded within, tearing it right out of its body.

The demon fell directly to the ground afterward, but it wasn't dead yet.

It slowly got back to its feet and looked at Yuan with a puzzled face.

"What the fuck are you doing? Did you really think that by removing my crystal that it'd kill me?" The demon asked Yuan.

"You can beat me up as much as you want, but you won't kill me, and you will eventually run out of spiritual energy. You can try to seal me, but that also will only prolong your life by a little longer. You don't have the capabilities to kill me—"

The demon suddenly halted its speech when it realized that its crystal was not returning to its body.

Normally, when their crystal is removed, it would return to their body just like the rest of their body, hence the demon's confusion at this moment.

"You said that you wouldn't die even if I destroyed this crystal, right? Let's test that theory." Yuan showed the demon his hand, where its crystal was resting.

The demon immediately began sweating profusely.

The reason the demon said that it wouldn't die even if Yuan destroyed the crystal was simply because it didn't think that Yuan had the capabilities to truly destroy the crystal since it would simply recover just like the rest of its body.

"T-That's not possible! Y-You! Who are you?!" The demon roared at Yuan.

"You don't recognize me? I thought all demons would recognize my face." Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"Why the fuck would I recognize a nobody like—" The demon suddenly halted mid-sentence again, and it narrowed its eyes to focus on Yuan's face.

Perhaps its memories haven't fully resurfaced after being sealed for so long, but as it stared at Yuan's face, the more it got the feeling that it'd seen him somewhere before.

After digging through its memories, the demon finally realized why Yuan looked so familiar.

"Y-Y-You... It can't be!" The demon began shaking from top to bottom, and its prideful face became filled with fear.

"Hmm... What did I use to say...?" Yuan suddenly began pondering for some reason.

"Oh, right."

When he remembered, he slowly approached the demon with a mysterious smile on his face.

This was the perfect chance for the demon to strike, but it was so stricken by fear that it couldn't even move properly.

Once Yuan was standing right in front of the demon, he mumbled in a low but clear voice, "I wonder how your demon core will taste?"

Almost as though something had triggered inside the demon, it suddenly turned around and began running away like its life depended on it.

The scene of the demon running away in fear shocked Qi Fang and the others. They couldn't comprehend the situation, nor could they imagine what Yuan said to the demon that would make it react in such a manner.

However, before the demon could run very far, Yuan crushed the red crystal in his grasp, and the moment the crystal shattered, the demon also froze its

movements.

The next moment, almost like it'd suddenly turned water, the demon melted into a pool of red blood, leaving behind its demon core.

Yuan quickly went to pick up the demon core before putting it inside his pocket, saving it for later.

It was also at this moment that backup from the Qi Family arrived at the scene.

"Father! Mother! Qi'er! Are you guys hurt?! Where is the demon?!" The middle-aged man leading the reinforcements asked them.

Qi Man didn't say anything and merely lifted his hand to point at Yuan.

The middle-aged man turned to look in the direction, but he couldn't see any demons, only a young man.

"I am going to him!" Qi Fang suddenly said as she began running towards Yuan.

"W-Wait! Where do you think you're going?!" The middle-aged man shouted at her.

"The demon is already gone. That young man defeated it." Qi Huan said, which immediately sent shockwaves through their minds.

"What?! Who even is that kid?! I have never seen him before!" The middle-aged man exclaimed.

"A friend sent by the Lord of the Dragon Spiral Mountain." Qi Man said before following Qi Fang.

"Let's go." Qi Huan said to the middle-aged man, who was still puzzled about the situation and had no choice but to follow them.

A few moments later, everyone there gathered around Yuan and the puddle of blood.

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Chapter 773 - As Their Lecturer

"Yuan, is the demon really dead? It won't regenerate from this puddle of blood?" Qi Fang asked him once they got to him.

"I'm pretty sure that it's dead..." Yuan replied in a slightly dazed voice.

He didn't think he would be able to defeat such a powerful demon with seemingly no effort at all. Not only did his practice at the Demon Sealing Clan's Grand Library help him, but his memories as the Divine Paragon also greatly assisted him today.

'I still only have fragments of the Divine Paragon's memories. If I recover all of it, demons will no longer be a threat and will be no different than any other magical beasts...' Yuan smiled inwardly.

"Let's go back to the household now. You can tell us everything once you get yourself cleaned up." Qi Man said to Yuan.

He nodded and followed them back to the household.

Sometime later, after washing himself, Yuan met up with the Qi Family in the meeting room, and there were two more people there this time—the middle-aged man that came with the backup and a beautiful woman who looked almost like Qi Fang.

They were the current leaders of the Qi Family and Qi Fang's parents.

Once Yuan sat down, Qi Man immediately opened his mouth to speak, "After witnessing your fight today, I doubt you'll need our help with the demons at the Dragon Spiral Mountain, but since this is what we agreed on, we will help you."

Yuan then said, "You guys can prolong the seals on demons, right? I would like you to prolong the seals on the 11 demons to give us more time to prepare. The demon I fought today was much stronger than the one in the Jaded Garden, but the demons within the Dragon Spiral Mountain are even stronger than this one."

"I understand." Qi Man nodded.

The Qi Family has already been prolonging the seals on the 11 demons since ancient times, so even if Yuan didn't ask them, they would've done it anyway. Since they cannot kill the demons, their only option was to prolong their seals.

"If there's nothing else, I would like to return back home now." Yuan said a moment later.

"A-Actually, there is one thing..." Qi Man turned to look at the Manager, who nodded her head silently.

He then continued, "Yuan, I— the Qi Family has one last request for you. We'd like you to stay here a little longer as a lecturer."

"A what?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"A lecturer." Qi Man repeated.

"We'd like you to teach our demon sealers how to kill demons. As you probably already know by now, there are still more demons out there."

"Our Qi Family has tracked dozens of sealed demons across the world, but the only thing we can do is prolong their seal until their inevitable release. We want to be able to kill them just like you did today."

"W-Wait... Did you just say DOZENS of sealed demons?" Yuan had a look of disbelief on his face at this moment.

"Yes, and there could be even more that we don't know about, such as the one sealed in the Jaded Garden." Qi Man sighed.

"And you want me to teach the demon sealers in your family... I don't think I qualify..." Yuan shook his head.

"I-If you, who killed a demon, don't qualify to teach, then nobody in our family qualifies! Please! You're our only hope!"

"..."

Yuan took a moment to ponder.

After a few minutes of silence, Yuan asked him, "How long? I have to return home in three weeks."

"T-Then three— No! Two weeks is more than enough!" Qi Man raised three fingers before making it two.

Yuan nodded, "Okay, I will stay here for two more weeks to teach your Qi Family, but after that, I really have to return home."

"Thank you, Yuan!" Qi Man said with an ecstatic expression on his face.

"Then we will start tomorrow morning. I want to rest for the rest of today."

"Of course! Qi'er, bring him to his room!" Qi Man said to her.

"What? Why do I have to do that? We have servants for that..." Qi Fang frowned.

However, when she saw her grandparents and even parents' cold glares, she swallowed nervously and stood up.

"Let's go..." She said to Yuan without even looking at him.

"Did something happen between them?" Her mother asked the grandparents after they left.

"Not that I am aware of, but there's clearly something between them." Qi Man shook his head.

Meanwhile, Qi Fang brought Yuan to a small shed behind their main building, but it looked more like a place for tools than guests.

"This is my room?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"If you've got a problem with it, you can sleep outside." She coldly responded.

"Are you still mad at me for sealing you? I just wanted you to have a taste of your own medicine, that's all. Not to mention that you sealed me first."

"F-For a minute! You left me there for an entire day! Do you have any idea how terrifying it feels to be sealed for so long?! I really thought I was sealed for good!"

"In my defense, if the Chu Family didn't interrupt, I would've let you out sooner. Anyways, I helped your family defeat the demon, so let's call it even."

Qi Fang gritted her teeth in anger, but she did not release it.

After a moment of silence, she pointed at the large building not far away from the shed and said, "This doesn't mean I forgive you for what you did to me. If I let you live in this shed, my family would kill me, that's all."

She left Yuan alone immediately afterward.

Once Yuan entered the room and locked it, he sat down on the floor and retrieved the demon core.

After staring at it for a moment, he tossed it inside his mouth and swallowed it.

Immediately, he could feel a sudden surge of chaotic spiritual energy rushing into his body.

However, this demon core tasted and felt different than usual, and it was painful.

"AAAAHH!" Yuan suddenly released a loud roar that shook the building.

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Chapter 774 - Chaotic Energy

Shortly after consuming the demon core, Yuan began feeling pain all over his body, and his skin even began turning red, almost as though he was turning into a demon himself.

When Qi Fang, who was still in range, heard Yuan's screaming, she immediately turned around and ran to his building.

"Hey! What's going on?! Why are you screaming like that?! Open the door!" Qi Fang banged on the door as she shouted, but Yuan was obviously too busy to answer the door, and he was in too much pain to even hear her voice.

"Answer me when I speak to you!" Qi Fang did not have the patience and decided to kick the door down.

"Hey! What's wrong with you?! What did you do?!" Qi Fang was shocked to see Yuan writhing in pain on the floor, and his body was burning red.

Qi Fang went to pick him up, but she didn't know what to do from there, so she decided to put him back down and went to call for a doctor.

"W-Wait right here! I am going to get a doctor! Don't you dare die on me!" Qi Fang said to him before running for help.

Meanwhile, Yuan was busy trying to suppress whatever was acting up inside his body.

"You silly thing, how could you swallow a demon core belonging to an Elite Demon in your current state? You're like a child that puts anything you find into your mouth. You're courting death." The Divine Paragon's voice resounded inside Yuan's head.

"Elite Demon? What's the difference?!" Yuan cried inwardly.

"Just like how dragons have their own ranks that are based on the purity of their dragon blood, demons have their own ranks based on their demonic blood. All of the demons that you have been fighting before this one were just ordinary demons with ordinary demonic blood. This one, however, is an Elite Demon with purer demonic blood, and the purer the demonic blood, the stronger their chaotic energy."

"W-What happens if I consume something like that?!"

"If you were strong enough, nothing would happen, but you're not, so the chaotic energy is trying to destroy your body right now."

"Listen, if you don't quickly control the chaotic energy, your body will explode into a bloody mess."

"And how the hell am I supposed to do that?!" Yuan shouted out loud, feeling as though something was growing within his body.

"Haaa..." The Divine Paragon sighed.

"I will help you control the chaotic energy this time, but if this happens again, you will have to deal with it yourself."

After a moment of silence, Yuan suddenly stopped moving and returned to sitting in the lotus position.

He took a deep breath and began controlling the chaotic energy inside his body.

Very quickly, Yuan could feel his body returning to normal, and his spiritual energy was under control again. However, he could still feel something chaotic inside his body.

By the time Qi Fang returned with the doctor, Yuan had already controlled most of the chaotic energy, but it took him all of his energy to do so, causing him to pass out shortly after.

The doctor checked Yuan's condition afterward.

"How is he?" Qi Fang asked in a worried voice.

Despite her cold attitude towards Yuan, she actually cared about his safety, as he was their only hope in defeating demons for good.

"He seems fine for now, and his body is stable, but I will need to inspect his body further for a more accurate assessment." The doctor said.

"I understand."

Qi Fang went to notify her family and the Manager of the situation once she knew that Yuan was fine for the moment.

When her family heard this, they immediately panicked for the same reason Qi Fang had. If Yuan dies, their world and everyone living in it will all die to the demons.

"What happened? Why did he suddenly collapse?" Qi Man asked her.

"I have no idea. I sent him to his room, and after leaving him alone for a moment, I suddenly heard him screaming. When I arrived, he was on the ground and his skin was burning red. However, by the time I returned with a doctor, he was already back to normal."

"Looks like we can only ask him after he wakes up." Qi Huan sighed.

Sometime later, the Manager called Meixiu to let her know of the situation.

"What?! Yuan collapsed and is unconscious right now?! What happened to him?!"

"I was hoping you could tell me. Does he have any medical conditions that cause him to do this?" The Manager asked.

"No, not that I am aware of."

"So he's never done this before?"

"No."

"Can I go see him? I want to see his condition with my own eyes."

"I will have to ask the Qi Family for permission first. Give me a minute."
The Manager then asked the old couple since they were still together.

"Yuan's friend? Of course. Any friend of Yuan is also our friend." Qi Man quickly agreed.

"Alright, I will come pick you up. I should be there by midnight. Be ready by then." The Manager said to Meixiu before hanging up.

'What a pain in the ass...' The Manager sighed inwardly.

She didn't think she'd have to travel back and forth more than once, but alas.

While the Manager made her way back to the Dragon Spiral Mountain to pick up Meixiu, the Qi Family watched over Yuan, who would remain unconscious for the rest of the day.

After returning to the Dragon Spiral Mountain, the Manager reported the situation to the Lord before she went to pick up Meixiu.

"So that's what happened, huh... If you ask me, I think he tried to cultivate the demon core, since his symptoms sound exactly like what happens when someone tries to absorb a demon core like it's a monster core." The Lord said.

"If someone tries to cultivate a demon core, what will happen to them?" The Manager asked out of curiosity.

"Well, to put things simply— they will die a horrible death.. However, from what you told me, it appears that he's alive, so I doubt that's what happened."

Chapter 775 - Losing His Mind

"Anyways, as long as he didn't cultivate a demon core and he isn't dead, do whatever you can to keep him safe. Now that he's proven himself to be valuable, we cannot let him die. Use that treasure even if you have to." The Lord continued to speak.

"W-What?! You want to waste that precious treasure on him?!" The Manager was shocked.

"If it can keep him alive, yes. He's too precious for this world to die."

"B-B-But—"

"No buts! You may return to the Qi Family now."

"I understand..." The Manager sighed before going to Yuan's home to pick up Meixiu.

However, there was an additional person there.

"What's this? I only got permission for one person, not two." The Manager said as she glared at Chu Liuxiang, who decided to follow along after hearing about the situation.

"I am not going to stay here while Yuan is suffering! I am going to follow you even if it's the last thing I do!" Chu Liuxiang said stubbornly.

And she continued, "And my Master is from the Qi Family! They wouldn't refuse me!"

"Whatever. Just get in the car." The Manager said to them.

Once they were all in the car, the Manager began speeding down the mountain like she did with Yuan, but it wasn't as fast.

However, unlike Yuan, neither Chu Liuxiang or Meixiu said a word regarding her speed, and they would only ask her about Yuan's condition.

"Like I already said on the phone, I don't know what happened to him. If you want to know, you'll have to ask him after he wakes up."

Once they arrived at the airport, the Manager told the two of them to press the red button and watch the plane before going off to sleep, leaving them speechless.

Meanwhile, Qi Fang was ordered by her family to stay with Yuan until he wakes up.

"What?! Why do I have to babysit him all night?! I am not his nanny! Why are you guys treating me like this? Did I do something wrong?!"

"That's a great question. Did you do something wrong?" Qi Huan narrowed her eyes at Qi Fang.

Qi Man then said, "Although we don't know what happened between the two of you, whether you are in the right or wrong, you need to put all of that behind you. Yuan is a valuable friend that we cannot afford to offend. If you offended him in any way, apologize to him when he wakes up."

Qi Fang gritted her teeth, but she couldn't blame her grandparents for their decision, as she was mostly responsible for what happened on that day.

"I understand..." Qi Fang sighed.

"Good, then we'll leave Yuan in your hands." They left her alone with Yuan afterward.

Once her family left, Qi Fang went to one of the drawers and pulled out a tall bottle of alcohol and sat down at the table.

"How could they treat their most talented demon sealer like a babysitter? Damn it!" Qi Fang began chugging down the alcohol and complained after every swallow.

"Why am I being punished when they don't even know what happened?!"

"It's almost like they wanted someone to blame for his current situation!"

"I can't believe this!"

"Damn it all!"

While Qi Fang was chugging down her alcohol, Yuan was somewhere deep within his consciousness.

"Although I have managed to control and convert most of the chaotic energy inside your body, there is still some left, and while it won't kill you, you should still remove them as soon as possible, as it could not only affect your cultivation but also your mind." The Divine Paragon appeared inside Yuan's head to warn him.

"How do I do that?"

"Fortunately for you, who has the Heaven Refining Physique, you can just cultivate normally and push out the remaining chaotic energy with fresh spiritual energy. If it was anybody else, they would need a new technique and a lot of treasures." The Divine Paragon smiled.

"How long do I have before it starts affecting me?" Yuan then asked.

"This is your first time experiencing such a thing, so the backlash will be quick and fierce. You can expect a reaction as soon as you wake up."

"I-It's that bad?" Yuan swallowed nervously.

"What will happen to me?"

"Who knows. You'll probably lose your mind every once in a while, become quick to lose your tempers, and other nasty nature that demons

have, almost like you'd turned into a demon yourself."

Yuan was terrified when he heard such words.

"I-I am going to turn into a demon?! Does this mean I will crave human meat or kill humans?! I hope to god that doesn't happen!"

"Although that's possible, it won't happen with the amount of chaotic energy inside your body. However, it would be a good idea to limit your contact with others for the time being."

"Okay... I will have to delay the lecturers until I fix this situation..." Yuan sighed.

While Yuan slept peacefully, Qi Fang approached him with a drunk look on her face, still with a bottle of alcohol in her hands.

"You stupid little brat— Hic! This is all your fault... Hic!"

Once she was standing right beside the bed, Qi Fang would stare at Yuan's sleeping face in silence.

"Now that I look at you closely... Hic! You're quite handsome..."

"What you did today was also very handsome and admirable... Hic!"

"When I watched you fight the demon, my heart was beating like crazy, almost like I was having a heart attack... I have never felt anything like that before..."

After a moment of silence, Qi Fang suddenly lowered her face towards Yuan's sleeping face, kissing him on the lips.

She removed her lips a moment later and muttered in a low voice, "How can you sleep so soundly with a beauty like me in the same room? Hic!"

"Hey... Wake up and fight me... I'm going to avenge myself... Hic!"

Qi Fang began to slap Yuan's face lightly for a response.

"..."

When Yuan didn't respond, Qi Fang turned around and began walking away.

"How boring... Hic!"

After walking two steps, Qi Fang suddenly stopped walking when she felt someone grab her hand.

She turned around to see Yuan sitting up on his bed, and his eyes were open, but he didn't seem conscious.

However, Qi Fang was too drunk to notice that and continued to probe him.

"Hehe, so you wanna fight—"

Yuan suddenly yanked Qi Fang onto the bed.

"Hey! What are you doing? That hurts!" Qi Fang complained as she laid on the bed with Yuan.

She also felt a little wet for some reason, so she looked down, and to her surprise, the bottle of alcohol in her hands had spilled all over her body.

"Look at what you've done... Hic! Now I have to clean myself..."

Qi Fang began loosening the wet areas on her clothes, and when Yuan saw that, almost as though something had ignited inside him, he suddenly pounced on top of her and ripped her loosened clothes right off her body.

"..."

Qi Fang stared at Yuan's face with a dazed expression.

"You... have very beautiful eyes..." She muttered in a low voice, not sounding a bit concerned about being naked nor the situation they were in, even placing her hands on his cheeks and caressing them.

When she noticed Yuan staring at her bare chest, Qi Fang smiled and said, "Go ahead, you can touch them. It's your reward for dealing with the demon."

Despite his weird state, it was almost as though Yuan had been waiting for Qi Fang's approval, so when he got her approval, he immediately buried his face into her chest like a child embracing their mother.

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Chapter 776 - A Grave Mistake

"Yes... That's right... You can touch them all you want... Hic!"

"It's your reward for killing the demon... Hic!" Qi Fang spoke in a dazed voice as Yuan's face buried deeper and deeper into her bosoms.

This went on for a few moments until Yuan all of Yuan's movements suddenly halted.

"Hey... What's wrong? Hic!"

Yuan suddenly stood up and looked at Qi Fang with a tranquil expression on his face.

"You... should probably leave before we both make a grave mistake," he said in a calm voice.

"W-What?" Qi Fang's eyes widened with shock.

This shock snapped her out of her drunken state for a brief moment, but this brief moment of clarity was all that was needed for Qi Fang to realize what was happening and made a decision.

She quickly got out of the bed and put on her clothes before running out of his room with a flushed face.

Once she was gone, Yuan sat on the bed and smiled, "What a troublesome child. I hope this will teach you to not put everything in your mouth and that all actions will have consequences."

He closed his eyes and began to cultivate.

Meanwhile, inside his consciousness, Yuan sighed in relief.

"Thank you..." He bowed to the Divine Paragon, who'd just taken over his body.

"Why are you thanking me?"

"For taking over my body and stopping me, who cannot control myself right now."

The Divine Paragon started laughing.

He then said, "I told you, I cannot take over your body. I am merely a fragment of your memories. You acted on your own just now, just like when you fought and killed the demon. Perhaps your instincts kicked in or something."

"How is that even possible when I am not conscious?" Yuan frowned.

"Reincarnation is a wonderful thing, but it is also something that we do not fully comprehend, and you're no ordinary human."

"..."

After a moment of silence, Yuan spoke, "Since you're here, can you tell me about the Demonic Realm? You kind of left me hanging last time."

"I don't have the answers to your questions. If you want them, go to the Demonic Realm."

"That's clearly bullshit. Why else would you say that something bad will happen if I don't return?"

"Like I'd already said— it's probably your instincts that's telling you."

"Anyways, it's about time I go. I won't be able to save you a second time, so if you end up in that state again, you're going to have to take full responsibility."

"I know..." Yuan sighed.

"Do you really?" A mysterious smile appeared on the Divine Paragon's face as he disappeared.

The following morning, Qi Fang woke up in her bed to a head-splitting headache.

"Shit... I drank too much yesterday..."

She sat up with a painful expression on her face.

Once her head cleared a little bit, memories of what happened last night began flowing inside her head.

"S-Shit..."

"Fuck... Did I really do such a thing?! No way!"

Qi Fang quickly got dressed and rushed to Yuan's place.

"H-Hey! Wake up! Yuan! We need to talk!" Qi Fang banged on the door as she shouted in an urgent manner.

"Senior Qi, I am sorry, but can you leave me alone for a while? We can talk later... Once I fix myself..."

"L-Last night! Nothing happened last night, do you hear me?! I was not in the right state of mind! It was a mistake!"

"What mistake?" Qi Man's voice suddenly resounded behind Qi Fang, giving her the scare of her life.

"G-Grandfather! Nothing!" Qi Fang turned around with a nervous look on her face, but when she saw Chu Liuxiang behind him, she became even more nervous.

"L-Liuxiang?! W-What are you doing here?!" She stuttered nervously.

"I am here to see Yuan, of course," she said in a calm voice.

"Speaking of Yuan, why are you standing out here? I thought we told you to watch over him. How can you do that when you're out here and he's in there?" Qi Huan said to her.

"I-I left for just a minute, okay?! I made sure to watch him properly! I swear!"

"Whatever..." The grandparents were suspicious of her weird behavior, but they didn't think too much of it.

Meixiu went to the door and knocked on it, "Yuan? Are you awake?"

"M-Meixiu?! Is that you, Meixiu?! What are you doing here?!" Yuan's panicked voice resounded inside the building.

"I am also here as well!" Chu Liuxiang said loudly.

"L-Lulu as well...?"

"Can you open the door and let us in? We want to see if you're okay." Meixiu continued.

"..."

After a moment of silence, Yuan sighed, "Sorry, but I am a little sick right now. Can you all leave me alone for a few days?"

"You're sick? How so?"

"..."

Meixiu turned to look at Qi Man and the others and said to them, "Can you leave us alone for a moment?"

"Alright. If you need anything, let us know."

"Thank you." Meixiu nodded.

Once they left, Meixiu continued, "Yuan, it's just me and Chu Liuxiang now. You can tell us what happened."

Yuan sighed again before speaking, "I consumed a demon core, but this demon core was a little special, so I am now experiencing a little backlash. My mind is not in the right state right now, and I am afraid of hurting you and the others, so until I take care of this condition, I should not get close to anyone."

"I see... So that's what happened... Are you in pain right now?" Meixiu then asked.

"No, I am fine. I should be healthy again in a few days."

"I understand. If you need anything, we will be right out here."

"Thank you, Meixiu, and Lulu, for coming all the way out here."

"Anything for you, Yuan." Chu Liuxiang smiled.

"Anyways, what should we tell the others? I don't think we should let them know that he consumed a demon core..."

"Yes, you're right. Let's think of something.." Meixiu agreed with Chu Liuxiang, and the two of them began thinking of an excuse for Yuan's condition.

Chapter 777 - Destructive Urges

"Why don't we just tell them that it's a medical condition he has?" Chu Liuxiang asked.

"No, that won't work. I already told the Manager that there was no such thing."

"Oh! I know! We can tell them that it was caused by one of the techniques he's currently cultivating!"

Meixiu stared at her in silence for a few moments before nodding, "That will work."

"Okay, let's tell them that then."

Sometime later, the Qi Family returned.

"How is he doing?" Qi Man asked.

"He's doing fine. It's just the backlash of one of his techniques that he's currently trying to master, that's all. His episode should be cleared in a few days."

"It was caused by a technique? I have never heard of a technique that has made people sick before..." Qi Huan said in a worried tone.

"But as long as he's fine, I am relieved."

"If you need anything, just let us know. We've also prepared a room for you two." Qi Man said to them.

"It's alright, we will stay here with him." Chu Liuxiang said.

"Out here? In the cold? You know we cannot have our guests live in such conditions." They raised their eyebrows.

"Why don't the two of you take turns watching over him?"

The two of them exchanged looks with each other before nodding their heads.

"I can watch over him first." Chu Liuxiang said.

"We switch out every 8 hours?" Meixiu asked.

"Okay."

Meixiu then turned to look at Qi Man and asked him, "While she stays here, I would like to join your Qi Family's training sessions. You guys are taught to fight demons, right? I would like to learn."

A bittersweet smile appeared on Qi Man's face as he spoke, "If you want to learn, you already have the very best. I don't think we will be very helpful to you. In fact, I am now doubting if our training is even useful at all."

"Even then, I would still like to learn— at least until he recovers." Meixiu said.

"Alright. Training should be starting soon. Follow me."

Meixiu left the Qi Man and the others while Chu Liuxiang stayed behind.

"I will be right outside if you need me, Yuan."

She sat down in front of the door and began cultivating.

Meanwhile, Meixiu followed Qi Man to this area with a large building and a massive field in the front.

"There's a lot of people here..." She mumbled when she saw hundreds of people gathered outside the training field.

"My Qi Family has almost 2,000 people. Of course, they are not all family by blood. We take disciples from around the world and teach them how to seal demons. As for our fighting experience... We really have none."

"Have you ever fought a demon before?" Qi Man turned to ask Meixiu.

"No, I have not." She shook her head.

"I have seen dozens of demons throughout my life, but they were all already sealed, so I have never seen their prowess... at least until yesterday."

"When I first saw the demon unsealed for the first time, my entire body froze from shock, and my instinct was to run away as quickly as possible."

"Even though I didn't personally face the demon... Even though Yuan completely dominated the demon and made it look weak... I can tell that I am no match for the demon."

"And if someone like me is scared of demons, I cannot imagine how these young demon sealers will react before an unsealed demon— at least not with their current training."

"That's why I asked Yuan to be our lecturer. I'm certain that we can all learn something from him."

Sometime later, Qi Man brought Meixiu to the field.

When the instructors and the disciples saw Qi Man, they all stopped whatever they were doing and bowed to him.

"Greetings, Ancestor!"

"Listen up!" Qi Man spoke out loud.

"Due to some complications, our new instructor will not be here for a few more days. Therefore, you will train normally for now. My friend here will be joining your training today. Treat her well."

Everybody there turned to look at Meixiu. Many nervous gulps resounded from people that were taken aback by her beauty, and there were so many that it sounded really weird.

Meanwhile, inside his room, Yuan was trying to suppress his urges to destroy everything in the room.

If he so much as looks at anything, his destructive urges would flare up, so he locked his divine sense.

'Is this what causes demons' destructive nature? I only have some chaotic energy left in my body, yet the urges are still this strong. I cannot imagine what it must be like to be a demon that has to endure this for their entire life.'

If he had to endure this urge for the rest of his life, there was no doubt that he would eventually stop suppressing his urges and go wild.

When he realized this, Yuan stopped blaming demons as much, and he even pitied their tragic life.

However, there was another feeling in Yuan that was very worrisome for him, and that was the feeling from last night that hasn't been satisfied.

'Damn it, I am already trying my best to deal with my destructive urges. If I also have to control my sexual urges, I won't be able to cultivate at all!' He cried inwardly.

After pondering for a moment, Yuan cleared his throat and spoke out loud, "L-Lulu... Is Meixiu out there?"

"No, she went to train with the Qi Family. Do you need help?"

"Kind of... When will she come back?"

"Well, it's been two hours since she left, so she won't return for another six hours."

"Six hours..." Yuan's sighing voice could be heard from inside the building.

"If you need help, I can help you!"

"I-It's a little complicated. It's okay, I can just wait."

After a moment of silence, Chu Liuxiang's voice resounded, "Yuan... No matter how complicated it is, I want to help you! You have helped me so many times now, yet I have not been able to return the favor. Please, let me help you!"

The place turned dead silent after that.

Chu Liuxiang sighed in a dispirited manner, but just as she was able to give up, she heard the door behind her being unlocked.

"Come inside..." Yuan said to her.

"Coming!" Chu Liuxiang eagerly entered the building.

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Chapter 778: Starved Beast

"Yuan? What are you doing, standing so far away?" Chu Liuxiang asked him after entering the building and noticing that he was standing all the way on the other side of the room.

"I wanted to make sure that I don't accidentally hurt you." Yuan sighed.

"Ever since I consumed the demon core, I have been getting these unhealthy thoughts and the urge to destroy everything around me, and I am having a hard time controlling these emotions. I am worried that I might hurt you if you get too close."

Hearing Yuan's words, Chu Liuxiang smiled. She closed the door behind her and started approaching him in a calm manner.

"As long as I can help you, I don't care even if you hurt me."

Once she was close enough, she opened her arms and embraced Yuan.

"See? Everything is fine. Now, tell me what you need help with."

However, before Yuan could even respond, Chu Liuxiang felt something hard poking her legs.

She looked down, and to her absolute shock, there was a massive bulge in his pants.

Chu Liuxiang's mind blanked out for a moment while she processed the situation.

"In order for me to release the chaotic energy in my body, I must cultivate, but I cannot cultivate properly when I have to control so many emotions

and urges..." Yuan sighed.

Chu Liuxiang snapped out of her daze and looked at his handsome face.

"W-When you say you need help, do you mean... down there?" She asked him in a nervous voice.

"I tried doing it myself before, but that didn't work. If you don't want to help, I fully understand and won't blame you for not wanting to do something so... weird..."

After a moment of silence, Chu Liuxiang asked in a low voice, "Does Meixiu usually help you? You did ask for her just now..."

"T-That's..."

Yuan promised Meixiu that he would not tell anybody, but even an idiot could tell the truth after seeing his reaction.

A bittersweet smile appeared on Chu Liuxiang's face, and she said, "Believe it or not, I am not that surprised. It's a common thing amongst wealthy households such as the Yu Family. Meixiu, she was probably trained to do such things."

She took a deep breath and continued, "Since Meixiu is not here, I will help you out. Take off your pants and sit on the bed."

Yuan nodded, and while he took off his pants, Chu Liuxiang went to lock the doors.

When she turned around and saw Yuan sitting on the bed with his lower half completely naked, her entire body froze.

Even though this wasn't her first time seeing his lower half, and they have even taken baths together, the atmosphere was completely different, and Yuan's body didn't have this sort of reaction.

'Why are you getting nervous now, you idiot? You have been wanting to do this kind of stuff to him for a long time!' Chu Liuxiang cried inwardly to

calm herself.

Sure enough, it worked perfectly, allowing her to move her body again.

She walked in front of Yuan and kneeled before him.

Once she prepared herself, she extended her fair hands and grabbed the stiff rod between Yuan's legs and began stroking it.

"Ah! It hurts!" Yuan suddenly exclaimed, sucking in a breath of cold air.

"S-Sorry!"

Chu Liuxiang was surprised by his painful sound and immediately removed her hands.

'Am I doing something wrong? But I am doing exactly what the magazines instruct!' She wondered inwardly.

She looked at him and asked, "How does Meixiu usually do this?"

"Uh... I don't know how to explain it..."

The room turned dead silent as Chu Liuxiang began pondering.

"Okay, I know what to do."

She started moving closer to Yuan, and once she was close enough, she opened her mouth and sucked on his thing.

Yuan suddenly felt an incredible feeling around his thing, but since he didn't dare to use his divine sense, he could only imagine what Chu Liuxiang was doing to him.

"How is this? Does this hurt?" Chu Liuxiang asked him a moment later.

"No... It feels good."

Chu Liuxiang didn't say anything longer and continued to relieve him of his stress.

A few minutes later, Yuan said, "I-I cannot hold it any longer!"

Chu Liuxiang suddenly felt something warm gush inside her mouth. She subconsciously removed her mouth, and Yuan's white stuff shot all over her clothes and face.

"Wow..." Chu Liuxiang mumbled in an amazed voice afterward.

"Let me go wash myself first... Is there a bathroom in here?"

Chu Liuxiang stood up and looked around for a bathroom.

However, Yuan didn't respond.

"Yuan?" She turned to look at him, who was sitting on the bed with a dazed face.

"Yuan? Are you okay?" She approached him.

"Ah!"

Yuan suddenly grabbed her, tossed her onto the bed, and pinned her down.

Although his actions surprised her, she wasn't too worried since she knew that he wouldn't harm her.

"Yuan? What's happening?" She asked him.

Yuan opened his mouth slightly and uttered in a low voice while gnashing his teeth, almost as though he was trying to resist something. "I... cannot... resist... anymore...!"

Chu Liuxiang stared at Yuan's painful face with a blank expression.

Yuan suddenly shouted, "Leave! Leave this place immediately before I hurt you!"

However, Chu Liuxiang didn't move, and she even caressed his cheeks with her hand.

"Yuan... How can I leave you alone when you're suffering? When I absorbed the Flood Dragon's scale, you stayed with me, even suffering with me. Therefore, I am going to do the same. Let me help you... Let me suffer with you."

Yuan's body trembled when he heard her words.

"It's okay. I will be fine. I promise. Let it out— let it all out."

"I'm sorry..." Yuan muttered in a low voice right before he stripped Chu Liuxiang naked.

And for the next few minutes, like a starved beast that hasn't eaten in days, he tasted every inch of Chu Liuxiang's luscious body, leaving his saliva all over her body.

Chapter 779: Bruises

"Mmm... Ahhh..."

Chu Liuxiang moaned softly as Yuan licked and kissed her body from the top to bottom.

When Yuan reached the area between her legs, he grabbed her legs and opened it wide before pushing his face towards her bottom lips.

"Mmm!"

Chu Liuxiang's eyes widened with shock and her body twitched. She wanted to moan louder, but she didn't dare to do so, fearing that someone might overhear them.

She suddenly felt something small invading her cave and wriggling around like a worm.

'So... fierce!' She cried inwardly.

Once Yuan was satisfied, he removed his wet mouth from Chu Liuxiang's body and aimed his sword at the slit between her legs.

"W-Wait a second, Yuan. Give me a moment to pre—"

However, before Chu Liuxiang could even finish her sentence, Yuan suddenly moved, shoving his rod into her body completely.

"Mmmmh?!"

Chu Liuxiang nearly screamed from the pain, and it felt like her lower body had been ripped apart and torn in half. The pain was so excruciating that it

immediately made her eyes tear up and almost knocked her unconscious.

However, before she could even recover from her pain or adapt to it, Yuan started moving again, pounding his hips violently at her like a dog during mating season.

'It hurts! It really hurts!'

Tears flowed from Chu Liuxiang's eyes like a river, yet she remained still and allowed Yuan to ravage her body as he wished.

The pain was on par with the pain she felt when she absorbed the Flood Dragon's scale, but unlike then, this pain felt more realistic and a completely different kind of pain, not to mention how tightly Yuan was holding onto her arms and legs.

A large amount of blood flowed from Chu Liuxiang's body and tainted the clean bed sheets, but Yuan ignored all of that and continued to thrust his hips like a machine with only one purpose.

Chu Liuxiang could've never expected that her first time with Yuan would be so brutal and so rough. She thought it was going to be a great time—one that could be enjoyed by the two of them, but it was more of a torture than anything.

Many minutes into their action, Yuan suddenly extended his arm and wrapped his hands around Chu Liuxiang's neck and tightened it, choking her neck.

Despite this, Chu Liuxiang accepted everything Yuan threw at her. She endured the pain, she resisted the thought of running away, and she tried her best to not blame Yuan for his actions.

"Yuan..." Chu Liuxiang muttered in a low voice as Yuan continued to seal away her air.

Yuan's body jolted the moment he heard Chu Liuxiang calling his name, and he slowly released his grasp on her neck, which left behind a slight

bruise.

"L-Lulu... What have I done...?" Yuan, who'd just regained control over his body, mumbled in disbelief.

He looked at her condition with his divine sense, and he could see bruise marks all over her body that had been caused by his rough handling, and the bed sheets were soaked in her blood.

However, despite the abuse she just experienced, Chu Liuxiang had a gentle smile on her face.

"Don't blame yourself, Yuan. You're not in the right state of mind, and I agreed to this."

"T-That doesn't make the situation any better, nor does it excuse my actions... I hurt you... even though I promised to protect you..."

"W-We need to stop here and get you a doctor—"

When Yuan tried to stand up, Chu Liuxiang suddenly grabbed his arm and pulled him back down.

"No! We cannot stop here! We need to finish this properly! I have always wanted to do this with you, too!"

"But your condition..."

"Don't underestimate me, Yuan. I got worse injuries when I trained with my Master, and it was much more painful when I absorbed the Flood Dragon's scale. I can handle this," she said with a resolute face.

And she continued, "Furthermore, you're back to normal now. Things will only get better from here."

"What if I lose my mind again?"

"Then I will wake you up again."

Chu Liuxiang grabbed his cheeks and pulled his face towards her own, kissing him on the lips.

"I love you, Yuan," she said to him afterward.

"Let's finish this so that you can get better."

Yuan nodded, and he inserted his rod into her body again.

Now that Yuan regained his senses, he no longer moved like a beast, allowing the both of them to enjoy the moment.

Eventually, Yuan reached his limits, and when that happened, he remembered Meixiu's words and pulled out of Chu Liuxiang before releasing his fluids all over her body.

Yuan proceeded to lay on the bed beside Chu Liuxiang, and the both of them rested for many minutes before they went to wash each other.

"Yuan, that was amazing. I never expected that embracing your loved ones could be so much fun and enjoyable— even if you were a little rough at the beginning." Chu Liuxiang suddenly said.

"Sorry..."

"Why are you apologizing? Some people like it rough, you know? It's like a hobby for them, and after experiencing it for myself, I can understand where they are coming from."

Yuan didn't know how to respond to such information, so he remained quiet.

"I am going to cultivate now and get rid of the chaotic energy within my body." Yuan said to Chu Liuxiang afterward.

"Good luck. If you ever need to 'relieve' yourself again, I will always be there for you."

"Thank you." Yuan nodded.

Chu Liuxiang left Yuan alone and proceeded to stare at the cloud in the sky with a dazed face until Meixiu returned.

"Is everything okay?" Meixiu asked Chu Liuxiang when she noticed the odd atmosphere around her, like something about her had changed.

"Never been better." Chu Liuxiang nodded with a smile.

"It's my turn to watch Yuan now."

"Okay."

Just as Chu Liuxiang began walking away, Meixiu suddenly spoke, "Wait."

"What's the matter?" Chu Liuxiang stopped and looked at her.

Meixiu raised her arm and pointed at her neck, "You're bruised... Something did happen, right? Are you okay?"

Chu Liuxiang subconsciously covered her neck. She had completely forgotten about it.

"Don't worry, it's really nothing serious."

"Yuan... Is he okay?"

"Yes, I promise.." Chu Liuxiang smiled at Meixiu before leaving the scene.

Chapter 780: Full Recovery

After Chu Liuxiang left, Meixiu turned to look at Yuan's building with a worried look on her face.

"Yuan... Are you there?"

"Yes."

"Are you okay?"

"..."

After a moment of silence, Yuan responded, "I lost control for a bit, but Lulu helped me, so I am fine now."

'Lost control? That explains the bruises on her neck... They probably fought.' Meixiu sighed inwardly, misunderstanding the situation entirely.

"Yuan, if you feel like losing control again, let me know and I will immediately get help." Meixiu said to him.

As much as she wanted to help him, she knew that she was no match for Yuan if they fought, so she could only rely on others for now.

'I am still too weak compared to them...' Meixiu bit her lips in frustration before sitting down and cultivating.

Eight hours passed in a flash while Meixiu focused on cultivation, and before she was aware, Chu Liuxiang was already back for her shift.

"I can continue. You should rest a little more." Meixiu said to her.

"Thank you for worrying about me, but I am really fine. Look, the bruises are already gone." Chu Liuxiang showed Meixiu her neck, and sure enough, all of her bruises were gone.

Meixiu silently stared at her for a moment before speaking, "If anything happens, you need to get help."

"I will." Chu Liuxiang nodded with a smile on her face.

Once Meixiu left, Chu Liuxiang sat before the building and said, "I am back, Yuan. If you need me, I will be out here."

There was no response from Yuan, but Chu Liuxiang didn't panic.

'He's probably focused on his recovery,' she thought to herself.

An hour into her shift, Chu Liuxiang noticed a figure in the distance, and they appeared to be watching her from the shadows.

It was already dark outside, so Chu Liuxiang couldn't see this figure's face.

"Who's there?" She called out to the figure.

A few seconds later, this figure stepped out of the shadows and into the light.

It was Qi Fang.

"Master? Do you need something?"

"How is he doing?"

"Yuan? He's recovering."

"Is that so." Qi Fang didn't say anything else and turned around and began walking away.

"Master! Wait a moment!" Chu Liuxiang stopped her.

"What?"

"A-Are you still angry at Yuan for what happened last time? If you are, please accept my apologies for him..."

"..."

Qi Fang spoke after a moment of silence, "I am more angry at myself than I am with him."

"Eh?" Chu Liuxiang's eyes widened.

"I thought I was strong. Strong enough to defeat him— strong enough to defeat a demon. Turns out that I've been wrong this entire time."

"You don't have to worry. What happened at the Chu Family is already behind me. I may be stupid and arrogant, but I am not foolish."

And without explaining any further, Qi Fang disappeared back into the shadows, leaving Chu Liuxiang speechless.

Two days later, Yuan opened his eyes and stood up to stretch.

"The urges are completely gone now, which means I have fully recovered. What a horrible experience. I swear I will never carelessly swallow demon cores ever again."

He opened the door and walked outside to see Chu Liuxiang sitting in front of him.

And when Chu Liuxiang heard the door open behind her, she stopped cultivating and turned around.

"Yuan! Have you finally recovered?" She quickly stood up and asked him.

"Yes, and it's all thanks to you."

Yuan suddenly opened his arms and embraced Chu Liuxiang tightly.

"Lulu... I am truly sorry about what happened last time. I asked you for your help, but that caused you a lot of pain. Even if I wasn't in the right state of mind, I am still responsible for my actions. I hope that you'll forgive me."

"I will forgive you... If you do it properly next time." Chu Liuxiang hugged him back and said.

"Let's wait until we go back home?"

"I think I prefer that as well." Chu Liuxiang chuckled.

"Let's go tell the others that you're fine." She then said.

"Okay."

Yuan and Chu Liuxiang went to meet up with Meixiu.

"Meixiu, are you awake?"

"Yuan!" Meixiu stopped cultivating when she heard Yuan's voice outside her room.

"Are you okay?" She asked him after opening the door.

"Yes, I have fully recovered. Thank you for watching over me."

"Where is the Qi Family? I'd like to speak with them."

"Senior Qi should be at the training area with the disciples. We can ask her." Meixiu said.

"Where is this place?"

"Follow me. I have been there before."

They made their way to the training area next, and sure enough, Qi Fang was training the disciple with an iron fist.

"Your demon sealing aura is too weak! Are you trying to seal the demon or unseal it?!"

"Senior Qi, I think they are looking for you." One of the disciples noticed Yuan's group and notified her.

When Qi Fang saw Yuan's face, she immediately recalled the incident they had not long ago and started blushing.

Sometime later, she approached them and asked, "Need something?"

Yuan smiled and said, "I have fully recovered, and I am prepared to train the Qi Family."

Qi Fang narrowed her eyes at him, "Are you sure?"

"I am." He nodded.

"Wait right here. I am going to notify my grandparents." Qi Fang then walked away for a few minutes before returning.

"They will be here shortly."

"While we wait... I need to speak with you... In private." Qi Fang looked at Yuan.

Qi Fang then dragged Yuan to a secluded area where they were alone.

Once Qi Fang was certain that nobody was around, she pointed at Yuan and spoke in a low but aggressive voice, "What happened that night never happened, okay?! I was drunk, and you were sick! Forget about it! If you dare tell anyone about it, I will kill you even if it's the last thing I do, and then I will kill myself! Do you hear me?!"

Yuan smiled and said, "What happened that night? I don't remember very clearly since I was sick."

"That's a good response. Now keep it that way— forever.." Qi Fang coldly snorted before walking away like nothing ever happened.

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Chapter 781: Lecturing The Qi Family

By the time Yuan returns to the others after his brief conversation with Qi Fang, Qi Man and the others have already arrived.

"Yuan! Are you sure you want to start the training already? You can rest a few more days if you want." Qi Man said to him.

"I am certain." Yuan nodded with a confident smile.

"Okay. Follow me, I will introduce you to the family." Qi Man said.

Qi Man brought Yuan before the disciples.

He cleared his throat and spoke, "Listen up! This person right here is Senior Yuan, and he will be your instructor for the next few days!"

The disciples immediately began mumbling to each other.

"He's our instructor? He looks even younger than me!"

"I don't believe it... This must be a prank."

"Shut up!" Qi Man suddenly shouted, instantly silencing the murmurs.

"He may be younger than most of you, but I can guarantee his skills and knowledge. As you already know, the demon on this island had escaped from its seal a few days ago. It was Senior Yuan who subjugated and killed the demon, saving us from a slaughter. If you dare disrespect him, you will answer to me!"

"In fact, all of the elders in the family will also participate in the lectures, as I firmly believe that we all have a lot to learn from him."

The disciples were shocked to learn that Yuan was the one who killed the demon, and they all wondered where he came from.

However, a few disciples there recognized his name.

"Wait... Yuan... He can't be Player Yuan, right? The mysterious player who seems to always be a thousand light years ahead of everyone?"

"Fuck... Now that you mention it, it would make perfect sense if it's Player Yuan. He always seems to achieve the impossible."

"So that's what Player Yuan looks like behind his mask, huh? Why does he have his eyes closed?"

"Who knows."

Yuan suddenly stepped forward and said, "Hello, everyone. I'm Yuan, and I will be teaching you all I know about demons. Before I teach you about how to fight demons, you should all know about demons' strengths and weaknesses."

He looked around before turning to look at Qi Man and asking him, "Is there a more suitable place for lectures?"

"Of course. We have a lecture hall not far from here. We can go there."

"Great."

Yuan and everyone there proceeded to follow Qi Man to the lecturer hall.

Once everyone was seated, Yuan began speaking, "Before I talk about demons' weakness, I want to talk about what makes them so strong and unkillable."

"First of all, demons have an incredible level of pain endurance. You can tear their limbs and smash their heads into meat paste, but they will not feel

a thing."

"Second, they all have powerful innate strength. If you try to fight them head-on, you will most likely lose."

"Demons are naturally stronger than humans, meaning if there is a demon and a cultivator with the same cultivation, the demon will always beat the human."

"Last but not least, demons have super regeneration, which allows them to recover from any damage as long as there is a tiny piece of their body left. You can decapitate them or grind them into a million pieces, they will still recover as though nothing had happened. This is demons' strongest ability and what makes them relentless and unkillable."

The disciples immediately began mumbling to each other.

"Fuck... I thought their regenerating abilities were exaggerated! To think it was true!"

The disciples despaired upon learning this information.

They learned about demons' regenerative abilities through ancient texts from their ancestors, but since they have never fought a demon before, they could never confirm the information.

"If we cannot kill them, then how did you kill the demon?" Someone there stood up and asked Yuan.

Yuan turned to look at the young man who just spoke and said, "They may be unkillable, but that is only for your average cultivator. We, demon sealers, have what it takes to kill demons as long as you know the right techniques."

"Now let me tell you about their weaknesses and how you can kill demons."

"There are two ways that I know of."

"One, you must destroy the demon faster than it can regenerate, meaning you can kill a demon as long as you can erase a demon completely before they can regenerate, but that will require a massive amount of spiritual energy and a technique that is powerful enough to do such a thing."

"As for the second method, you must destroy their core. All demons have a core in their body— it's the red crystal that can usually be found on their chest. If you can destroy their core, the demon will lose their regenerative ability and die, which is what I did to the demon."

"However, in order to do that, you must have the right technique and demon sealing aura strong enough to prevent the crystal from returning to the demon."

"I will now answer any questions that you may have."

Dozens of hands immediately raised into the air.

"How many demons have you fought— killed?!" A young lady asked him with her eyes flickering with admiration.

"A couple."

"Are you really Player Yuan?! The number one player in Cultivation Online?!"

"Yes, I am."

"D-Do you have a girlfriend?!"

"..."

"Let's try to stay on topic..." Yuan said with a bittersweet smile on his face.

Qi Fang suddenly stood up and asked, "The two methods to kill a demon— they all require a specific technique, but we don't have such techniques. Are you telling us that we will never be able to kill demons?"

Yuan smiled upon hearing her question, and he responded in a clear voice, "That's not true. You may not have such techniques, but I do. If you want, I can teach you these techniques."

"What? Are you serious?" Qi Fang's eyes widened with shock.

Qi Man and the other elders were also pleasantly surprised to hear Yuan's words.

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Chapter 782: Lecturing The Qi Family(2)

"Y-You're willing to share with us your demon sealing techniques? What do you want in return? I doubt you'll be willing to give them for free." Qi Fang narrowed her eyes at Yuan.

The situation sounded too good to be true.

"I don't need or want anything from you. I believe that the more capable demon sealers there are in this world, the safer it is from demons. It makes no sense for me to keep demon sealing techniques to myself when the world is in danger, as that would be akin to asking you to dig a hole with your bare hands while I keep all of the tools necessary to dig the hole to myself."

"However, these techniques require a certain amount of demon sealing aura to use. If your demon sealing aura is too weak, you will not be able to learn it."

Qi Man suddenly stood up and spoke in a loud and excited voice, "As you all have just heard, Senior Yuan has agreed to teach us his valuable demon sealing techniques! However, if you want to learn them, you must qualify first! If you wish to learn from him, you must speak to an elder first so that you don't waste Senior Yuan's time!"

"Thank you, Senior Yuan!"

The disciples all expressed their gratitude to him.

Yuan nodded, and he continued to lecture the Qi Family about demons for an hour before they all returned to the training area.

"Now that you all know about demons, you should learn to fight them. Starting today, I will be acting as a demon, and your goal is to 'seal' me."

"Seal you? How do we do that?" One of the disciples asked.

"Just treat me like a demon and try your best to seal me."

"Are you sure? That sounds a little dangerous."

Yuan smiled and said, "Yes, it's going to be a little risky, but not for me."

He pointed at them and said, "If anyone here can defeat me, I will teach you a demon sealing technique of your choosing. I happen to know a couple of Divine-rank demon sealing techniques, after all."

When the disciples heard Yuan's words, they immediately felt a rush of excitement and passion in their body.

"Who wants to try first?" Yuan asked them a moment later.

And before anybody could even move, a figure landed before him.

"I will go first." Qi Fang said with a serious look on her face.

She had multiple reasons to fight Yuan, but she never had the right excuse until now.

"Sure." Yuan nodded with a smile.

Qi Fang retrieved a sword.

"Where's your sword. Take it out."

"It won't be fair if I use it." Yuan said.

"How arrogant!"

Qi Fang didn't say anything else and kicked her feet.

However, a burst of intense killing intent suddenly exploded from Yuan, halting Qi Fang instantly.

"Demons will have much more killing intent than I am releasing now! You must overcome your fear, or you will never defeat the demon!" Yuan said to her in a loud voice so that everyone else could hear him.

Qi Fang's body trembled in fear, but she gritted her teeth and forced her own body to move.

"Haaaa!"

She swung her sword at Yuan with all of her might, but Yuan dodged it effortlessly.

"I can tell that you're still scared! Get rid of your fear if you want to win!"

"Shut up! That's easier said than done!" Qi Fang continued to swing her sword at Yuan, but with her body still trembling, she could barely control her movements.

"If I was a real demon, you'd been dead a dozen times by now." Yuan suddenly appeared behind Qi Fang, kicking her on the side and sending her flying.

He turned to look at the dazed spectators and shouted, "If you do not overcome your fear, you will never defeat the demon! There is nothing to fear as long as you have your demon sealing technique! Demons should fear you, not the other way!"

"Who wants to try next?!"

After a moment of silence, over a dozen disciples raised their hands.

Seeing this, Yuan pointed at 5 different people and said, "You can all come at me together."

The five disciples exchanged looks with each other before nodding their heads.

Once they were prepared, they surrounded Yuan and attacked him at once.

However, Yuan released his killing intent again.

The disciples suddenly felt as though the grim reaper had appeared to take their lives, and their legs began shivering nonstop.

While the disciples were dazed, Yuan used this chance to attack them, quickly defeating all five disciples.

"Give me ten disciples next!" Yuan turned to look at the spectators.

And for the rest of the day, Yuan would fight every disciple in the Qi Family without a single loss, even increasing the number of people he fought at once after every victory.

"Fuck! He's too powerful!"

"So this is what it feels like to fight Player Yuan, huh? As expected, he's on a whole other level."

Sometime later, Yuan gathered everybody and said to them, "Although nobody has managed to resist my killing intent today, I have confidence in you all. Therefore, we will spend all day tomorrow increasing your endurance to my killing intent."

Once the disciples were dismissed, Qi Man and the other elders approached Yuan.

"Yuan, do you think we have enough demon sealing aura to learn the techniques?" Qi Huan asked him.

"I don't know. Do you guys have anything that measures one's demon sealing aura?" He asked them.

Qi Man then said, "We do. It's also what we use to determine if someone has the capabilities to become a demon sealer. Follow us."

They brought Yuan to an open area where a stone tablet surrounded by seven stone totems existed.

"If we pour our demon sealing aura in the stone tablet, it will tell us the strength of our aura, but we're not exactly sure how it scales." Qi Man said to him.

"We'll find out in a bit, I guess.." Yuan said.

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Chapter 783: Testing Their Demon Sealing Aura

"I will go first." Qi Man said as he approached the stone tablet.

He placed his hands onto the tablet and poured his demon sealing aura into it.

One of the seven stone totems began emitting a dim light, then two totems, then three, stopping at four totems.

"Four totems... I think it should be good enough. I will transfer the technique to you. See if you can comprehend it." Yuan said to him afterward.

"How will you...?" Qi Man raised his eyebrows.

Yuan approached Qi Man and lifted his hand before poking Qi Man's forehead with his finger that had a subtle light emitting from the tip.

The next moment, Qi Man could feel something being forced into his head, and the demon sealing technique appeared inside his mind like some sort of magic trick.

"Heavens! You can even do something like this?" Qi Man was shocked and speechless.

"I only learned this technique very recently, but it allows me to transfer any technique I know to others. It's very convenient."

Qi Man wasted no time and took a seat not far away before he started trying to comprehend the demon sealing technique.

"Who's next?"

"I will go next!" Qi Huan stepped forward and placed her hands onto the stone tablet.

A few moments later, three stone totems emitted light.

Yuan transferred the demon sealing technique that will allow them to destroy a demon's core to Qi Huan afterward.

Up next was Qi Fang's father, followed by her mother.

Her father managed to light up four totems while her mother only managed to light up three totems, just like Qi Man and Qi Huan.

The other elders went next, but most of them only managed to light up two totems with a few lighting three.

Once all of the elders were finished, Qi Fang went to check her results, but she already knew the results before even putting her hands on the stone tablet since it was mandatory to check their demon sealing aura once a year, and she'd checked her demon sealing aura two months ago.

One totem... two totems... three totems...

In the end, Qi Fang managed to light up five totems, which is the highest out of the entire Qi Family.

"As expected of our family's number one genius..." The other elders were not surprised by the results.

After getting her demon sealing aura tested, Qi Fang approached Yuan and waited for him to transfer the techniques to her.

"Senior Qi, what weapon do you mainly use? The sword?"

"Yes." Qi Fang nodded, silently wondering to herself why he was asking this question.

"Then I will give you a demon sealing technique for the sword as well as the technique that will allow you to destroy their cores."

"Really?" Qi Fang's eyes began flickering with excitement.

"Why would I lie to you?" Yuan smiled as he transferred the Demon Sealing Strike and the other technique that he gave everyone else to Qi Fang.

"This is... What a profound technique..." Qi Fang mumbled in awe as she closed her eyes to look at the information flowing inside her head.

"What about you two? Do you want to test your demon sealing aura?" Yuan asked Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang.

"Sure." They nodded.

Chu Liuxiang went first, followed by Meixiu.

However, to their surprise, they were only able to light up a single totem.

"Does this mean we're not suitable to become demon sealers?" Chu Liuxiang asked him in a worried tone.

"No, your results are normal for people that have never trained their demon sealing aura before." Qi Man said to them.

"As long as you continue strengthening your demon sealing aura, you will be able to light up more totems. In fact, most of us started out with only one totem as well."

Chu Liuxiang and Meixiu felt more reassured after hearing Qi Man's explanation.

"How does one even train their demon sealing aura?" Chu Liuxiang then asked.

"We're not entirely sure either, but we found that the more we comprehend demon sealing techniques, the stronger our demon sealing aura becomes."

Qi Man responded.

"Does this mean one should study as many demon sealing techniques as they can even if they cannot use some of them?"

"Yes." Qi Man nodded.

"Anyways, this technique is very profound. It will take us a few weeks if not months before we get any results."

"However, I think we can teach everyone that has at least level 2 demon sealing aura the technique, but it's all up to you, Yuan." Qi Man looked at him.

"Level 2 demon sealing aura? So only those who can emit light from two totems should learn the technique?" Yuan asked for confirmation.

"Yes." Qi Man nodded.

"Sure, I don't mind."

"Thank you. This debt we owe you is so huge that I don't even know where to begin, much less how to repay you. Please give us some time to think of a proper response." Qi Man lowered his head and said.

Yuan pondered for a moment before speaking, "I don't really need any payments, but I would appreciate it if you can let me look at the Qi Family's demon sealing techniques."

"Of course! We don't have much, and they are worthless compared to your demon sealing techniques, but since you asked, you may look at them as you please. Just let me know when you want to look at them."

"I will look at them before I return home." Yuan said.

Sometime later, Qi Fang stopped trying to learn the technique and said to Yuan, "Hey, why don't you take the test as well? I want to see how strong your demon sealing aura is."

When the others heard Qi Fang's suggestion, they also stopped cultivating and stared at Yuan. It was clear as day that Qi Fang isn't the only one curious.

"Sure." Yuan simply couldn't refuse after seeing their anticipating gazes.

He approached the stone tablet and placed his hands on it.

After taking a slow and deep breath, Yuan released his demon sealing aura.

The second the stone tablet sensed his demon sealing aura, it immediately responded by trembling violently.

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Chapter 784: Killing Intent

When Yuan felt the stone tablet shake, he subconsciously removed his hand from it, fearing that he might destroy it.

However, it was too late, as he'd already injected his demon sealing aura into the stone tablet.

The stone tablet began trembling until cracks appeared on it.

When Qi Fang and the others saw this, they were terrified out of their minds. If the stone tablet really breaks, they would have no way to fix it!

Suddenly, all seven totems shone brightly, basking the whole area with a golden light.

Boom!

One of the seven totems—the very last one—exploded into countless pieces.

When that happened, the other six totems lost their light, and the stone tablet stopped working.

"W-What the hell did you do...?" Qi Fang approached the totems in a dazed manner, and she inspected the conditions of the remaining six totems.

Although they were not completely destroyed, they were on the verge of destruction, and they were all covered in cracks.

"S-Sorry! I think my demon sealing aura was too strong!" Yuan quickly apologized.

"You think an apology will fix this? If this stone tablet stops working, we will no longer be able to evaluate the strength of our demon sealing aura!" Qi Fang said with a frown.

"I only did as you told me." Yuan shrugged.

"Calm down." Qi Man suddenly said.

"Even if the stone tablet is broken, not all hope is lost. The other two families also have one."

"Other two families?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"There are three ancient families in this world that seal demons, and the Qi Family is only one of them. The other two would be the Luan Family and the Sang Family. We don't normally speak with each other, but if we really need to, we can ask to use their stone tablet."

"Don't worry about this, Yuan. We will deal with the stone tablet. You can focus on your lectures."

"I understand. Once again, sorry about the whole situation."

While Yuan returned to his living quarters, the Qi Family examined the damages done to the stone tablet much deeper.

"I have never seen anything like this before. Just how powerful is his demon sealing aura to wreck the place like this?"

"He's strong enough to kill a demon, so I'm not really that surprised..."

Sometime later, the people that inspected the stone tablet reported the results to the elders.

"Despite its rough state and appearance, the stone tablet is still working properly— except the seventh totem, which is no longer functional."

Qi Huan released a long sigh after hearing the results, "Looks like we won't have to beg the other two families for their help."

"Indeed." Qi Man sighed.

Meanwhile...

"Okay, I am going to transfer to you the demon sealing techniques now."
Yuan said to Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang.

He started with Meixiu.

After touching her forehead with his finger, Yuan transferred two different techniques to her, both demon sealing techniques that required the bow.

"A Heaven-rank and Divine-rank technique..." Meixiu mumbled in a low voice.

"Thank you, Yuan."

Yuan turned to look at Chu Liuxiang next.

"I have three demon sealing techniques for you, and they don't require the usage of any weapons." Yuan said to her before transferring the techniques to her.

"Thank you!" She said to him afterward.

"Good luck learning the techniques."

The following morning, Yuan went to the training area.

"Yuan, I also want to participate in the training today." Meixiu suddenly said to him.

"Sure."

"I also want to join!" Chu Liuxiang said.

And she continued, "Make sure that you don't go easy on us."

"I won't." He smiled.

Sometime later, they arrived at the training area.

While they waited for everyone to arrive, Qi Man approached Yuan and told him about the stone tablets.

"So they still work? Thank god." Yuan sighed in relief.

"Only six of the seven totems work, but I doubt any of us will reach that level."

"Nothing is impossible." Yuan smiled.

Once everyone from the Qi Family gathered at the training area, Yuan had them surrounded him in a circle.

The strongest cultivators there like Qi Fang and Chu Liuxiang sat closest to Yuan while the weaker cultivators sat further away.

"I will now release my killing intent. It will feel uncomfortable. Some of you might even feel pain, but do your best to endure it. This will not only help you fight against demons, it can also help you when you face other cultivators." Yuan said to them before taking a seat on the floor.

"Any questions before we start?"

One of the disciples raised her hands and asked, "Senior Yuan, how long do we have to endure your killing intent?"

"As long as you can. I will be doing this all day. If you must retire, leave. But if you want to come back afterward, you can do so."

Once there were no more questions, Yuan took a deep breath and turned dead silent.

After a moment of silence, an overwhelming amount of killing intent suddenly burst from Yuan's body like a volcano, shocking everybody there.

"Aaaah!"

Many disciples screamed in terror the moment they felt his killing intent, and some of them even fell unconscious.

Despite the chaos, Yuan continued to release his killing intent, filling the entire training area with it.

"T-This guy..." Qi Fang couldn't stop her body shaking from fear, and her body quickly became soaked in sweat.

Even the elders like Qi Man and Qi Huan couldn't sit still.

Eventually, Yuan had to lower the amount of killing intent he was releasing, as too many disciples were falling out too quickly, which would make his training less effective.

As for his killing intent, most of them were from his memories as the Evil God.

Killing intent can only be formed through one's experience as a killer, and with his memories as the Evil God, someone who has killed countless people, even a tiny amount of his killing intent was enough to render everyone in the Qi Family useless.

Chapter 785: Hovering In The Air

It did not matter if it was Meixiu, Chu Liuxiang, Qi Fang, or even the elders — none of them were able to endure Yuan's killing intent for more than 10 minutes continuously, or they would risk pissing their pants from fear.

The weaker disciples were even worse, giving up every two to three minutes before returning after a 15 minute break.

"How does he emit such strong killing intent? Do you think he's killed a lot of people before? After all, you can only acquire killing intent from killing things." The disciples mumbled to each other while they took a break.

"Honestly, I wouldn't be too surprised if that was the case. He's so damn powerful, who can stop him?"

"He can probably kill everyone on this island and get away with it..."

"I don't think he's a killer. He just doesn't give me that feeling. As for his killing intent, it could be acquired from Cultivation Online for all we know."

"If you have the time to talk, you have time to go back to training!"

"Y-Yes, Elder!"

And for pretty much the entire day, Yuan would remain seated at the center of these disciples, keeping his killing intent going.

Every hour, he would increase the killing intent slightly, so the disciples would never feel 'comfortable' with his killing intent, allowing them to improve at a steady and quick rate.

"I know I told you not to go easy on us, but heavens... I've never had such intensive training before..." Chu Liuxiang sighed out loud after the training ended, feeling sticky all over her body because of her sweat.

"Are you okay, Meixiu?" Yuan noticed that she was a little pale after the training.

"Yes, I am fine." She nodded in a dazed manner.

Yuan frowned and said, "You shouldn't push yourself so hard. You could hurt yourself."

"Don't worry, I will be fine after some rest." She smiled.

Even if Meixiu is a lot stronger than most people due to the treasure she consumed, not to mention her cultivation technique that trains the soul, she is still only a Spirit Warrior.

Yuan could tell that Meixiu was pushing herself to get stronger, most likely because she felt that she was too behind when compared to Chu Liuxiang and the others, but he wasn't sure how to convince her to slow down.

Sometime later, everyone returned to their room to rest.

They were so exhausted that most of them were knocked out before they could even change out of their clothes.

In fact, the entire island appeared to be deserted for the rest of the day, and the only ones walking around were the servants that did not participate in Yuan's training.

As for Yuan, even though it was also exhausting for him to keep releasing his killing intent, he would fully recover within an hour.

Once he fully recovered his energy, Yuan sat on his bed and began trying to use Qi Manifestation.

After consuming the demon core, his cultivation had a huge breakthrough, surpassing Spirit Master and soaring all the way to the 5th level of Spirit

Grandmaster.

Now that he was a Spirit Grandmaster, he wondered if he could learn Qi Manifestation and start flying in the sky like he does in Cultivation Online.

However, just like everything else, it was much more difficult to learn techniques in the real world than in Cultivation Online.

'I can release my spiritual energy outside my body, but I am having a hard time controlling it. This doesn't make any sense. How come I can learn everything with ease in Cultivation Online, yet everything feels more difficult in this world?'

'Does Cultivation Online somehow increase our comprehension level? It would make sense why things feel easier over there.'

After practicing his Qi Manifestation for pretty much the entire night, Yuan finally gained the ability to control his Qi Manifestation.

However, he does not seem to be able to fly just yet.

'I may not be able to fly without support, but what if I use a flying sword?'

Yuan summoned his Empyrean Overlord and proceeded to make it hover using Qi Manifestation.

Once he was comfortable with controlling the sword, he jumped onto the sword.

"Hahaha! It's working! I am hovering in the air!" Yuan laughed out loud as he hovered in the middle of the room while standing on his sword.

He immediately began working on his balance in the air, and once he was comfortable with that, he started controlling the sword to make it fly around the room.

This training made Yuan recall when he first learned how to balance on a flying sword after being taught by Xiao Hua.

After recalling Xiao Hua, Yuan suddenly had a realization.

'Wait a minute... If I can summon my Soul Weapons in this world, perhaps I can somehow summon Xiao Hua and the others into this world as well?'

The thought of summoning Xiao Hua and the others to this world was so outrageous that it never even appeared inside Yuan's mind, but now that he thought about it, he really wanted to see it happen.

Yuan quickly stopped his training and took a deep breath.

Once he cleared his mind, he tried to call for Xiao Hua and the others like he normally would in Cultivation Online.

'Xiao Hua? Can you hear me? Feng Feng? Yingying? If you can hear me, come out.'

Yuan tried calling them for five minutes straight, but he did not get any response from them.

"Fortunately, I kept my expectations down... But this begs the question—How come I can summon my Soul Weapons but not my servants? Is it because they are tools and not living beings? Or maybe Xiao Hua and the others are too far away to hear my summoning?"

He began pondering for a solution, but in the end, he returned to practicing flying around on his flying sword.

'Guess I will have to ask them about it when I return home.'

Chapter 786: Exhaustion

The following morning, Yuan went to meet up with Chu Liuxiang and Meixiu before going to the training area.

"How do you feel?" Yuan asked Meixiu as they walked to the training area.

"Much better." She nodded with a confident smile.

However, she still looked as pale as yesterday, which made Yuan worry a little.

"Are you sure? You should probably stay back and rest today." Chu Liuxiang said to her.

"Really, I am fine. I have experienced much worse before." Meixiu said.

"If you say so."

Once they reached the training area, Yuan would take a seat in the middle of the place and said to those that were already there, "I will begin now. Those that are not here right now can join later."

He waited until everyone there was sitting around him before he started to release his killing intent.

This time, he started out with weak killing intent and gradually increased it.

Even though the disciples had spent all day enduring the same killing intent yesterday, they did not feel any better today when being pressured by the killing intent.

In fact, it felt even worse for them, who were exhausted yesterday and haven't fully recovered.

Regardless, almost everyone that was there yesterday was also there today with a few exceptions, such as those that got sick or were too traumatized by yesterday.

However, about an hour into their training, Yuan suddenly stopped his killing intent and stood up in a panicked manner.

"Meixiu!"

He jumped over the crowd of disciples and landed in front of Meixiu, who'd just collapsed onto the ground.

His reaction was instantaneous, as he'd been keeping his divine sense on her the entire time.

"Haaa... haaa..."

Yuan could hear Meixiu breathing heavily, almost as though she was having trouble breathing.

"Is there a doctor here?!" He shouted out loud.

"Here!"

Because of their dangerous training method, the Qi Family made sure there were plenty of doctors on standby just in case anything were to happen.

Over a dozen doctors quickly surrounded Yuan and checked Meixiu's condition.

"She collapsed from exhaustion, and she has a fever. It's nothing life-threatening." The doctors explained to Yuan after their assessment.

"I see... Thank you."

Yuan picked up Meixiu before speaking out loud, "Sorry, but I am going to have to end today's training earlier than usual."

"Don't worry about it. If you need anything, let us know. There will be a doctor available for you around the clock until she is recovered." Qi Man said to him.

Sometime later, Yuan carried Meixiu back to her room and placed her on the bed.

"I knew something like this was going to happen when I saw her condition..." Chu Liuxiang sighed as she stood beside Yuan.

"I don't understand. Why is she working herself to such an extent?" Yuan shook his head.

If anything, Meixiu's workload has dramatically decreased since they left the Yu Family, so it didn't make sense for her to collapse from exhaustion. Just what on earth is she doing that's causing this?

"I'm sorry..." Meixiu suddenly mumbled in a low voice.

And she continued, "I didn't want to fall behind you and everyone else, so I worked extra hard to improve my cultivation."

"..." Yuan was speechless. He didn't think Meixiu would be worried about such a thing.

"How silly." Chu Liuxiang suddenly said, and she continued, "If you want to catch up to Yuan, you'll be chasing for the rest of your life, and even then, you won't catch up. If you're talking about everyone else, you've already caught up."

"You're a Spirit Warrior, right? There aren't many Spirit Warriors in this world even today. The Six Spiritual Families, the Chu Family, and the Qi Family—they're all abnormal families that have a huge advantage over everyone else because of their prior knowledge on cultivation. If you take

them out of the conclusion, you're one of the top cultivators in the world, so you shouldn't worry about catching up."

Yuan then said, "I don't want to sound arrogant, but Lulu is right, Meixiu. I can consume demon cores, and a single one of them increases my cultivation by leaps and bounds. Unless someone has the same physique, I cannot imagine how they'll achieve the same results without consuming a massive amount of treasures, and such treasures are not easily attainable in this world."

Meixiu had no response, as everything Yuan and Chu Liuxiang said was the truth. It was simply foolish of her to try and catch up to Yuan, who has heaven-defying talents that allowed him to achieve Spirit Grandmaster within a couple of months after he started cultivation.

"Anyways, get some rest. Seeing you like this, I also feel like resting some more. Yesterday's training was too stressful." Chu Liuxiang said a moment later.

"Sorry..." Yuan felt the need to apologize for some reason.

"Don't you dare make the training easier just because of this, though."

"I won't." Yuan smiled.

"If you need me, I will be right next door." Chu Liuxiang returned to her own room shortly after.

Once they were alone, Meixiu spoke in a low voice, "Yuan..."

"What's the matter? Are you in pain? I will immediately get the doctor—"

"No, that's not it." She quickly stopped him.

"My body is still soaked in sweat. I cannot go to sleep like this, and it'll dirty the bed..."

"Oh, sorry."

"Can you turn on the water for me so I can take a quick shower? I will be there in a bit."

"Of course."

Yuan went to the bathroom and turned on the shower for her.

Sometime later, Yuan returned to the room to see that Meixiu had just stripped naked.

"Can you help me to the bathroom? I cannot exert any strength for some reason..." Meixiu suddenly asked him.

Yuan nodded, and he asked, "Do you want me to wash your back as well?"

Meixiu's face flushed slightly redder after hearing his question, but she didn't refuse.

"If you don't mind," she nodded.

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Chapter 787: Taking Care Of Meixiu

"Why would I mind?" Yuan said as he walked next to Meixiu so that he could support her.

Meixiu wrapped her arm around his neck while Yuan held her by the waist, walking her to the bathroom.

Once they were inside the bathroom, Meixiu removed her bath towel and sat down on a small wooden chair.

"Can you hold the shower head for me?"

"Sure."

Yuan took the shower head and started rinsing her body.

"Okay, that's enough." She said a moment later.

"Should I wash your back now?" Yuan asked.

Seeing Meixiu nod her head, Yuan squeezed some body wash onto his palms before he started washing Meixiu's back with his bare hands.

'Her skin is so smooth...' Yuan thought to himself, and he couldn't help but recall the time when their naked bodies embraced each other.

Once Meixiu's whole back was covered in soap, Yuan said, "Okay, I am done."

However, Meixiu remained silent.

"Meixiu? Are you okay?" Yuan quickly asked her in a worried voice.

"Y-Yes. Sorry, I dazed out just now." She responded in a low voice.

Then she said, "Yuan... Can I ask you to wash my front as well?"

Perhaps it was because of her fever, or maybe it was because of the sensation of Yuan's hands on her back just now, but she felt hotter than usual, and that made her bolder than usual.

"T-The front? Of course..." Yuan was a little surprised to hear such a request, but he didn't refuse.

"Thank you..."

Yuan squeezed more body wash onto his palms before moving to the front, where he could see the best features on Meixiu's naked body.

After swallowing nervously, Yuan began washing Meixiu's front.

He started with her neck before going down to her breasts, then stomach.

Once he reached her legs, Meixiu willingly spread her legs for him.

Yuan took another deep breath before washing her legs, slowly moving towards the slit between her legs.

"Mmm..." Meixiu suddenly released a gentle moan when Yuan's fingers began rubbing against her sensitive spot.

When he heard this beautiful sound that tickled his ears and heart, Yuan's movement sped up a little, almost as though it was trying to match the pace of his heart that was also speeding up.

Meixiu's moans also got more constant and louder as the sensation of Yuan rubbing her slit became more intense.

A few moments later, when Yuan realized what he was doing, he quickly stopped and pulled his hand back.

"S-Sorry, my body acted on its own just now..." He apologized.

"It's okay. I didn't dislike it either." She said with a gentle smile on her face.

Yuan swallowed hard after hearing her words.

"A-Anyways, let me rinse you off before you catch a cold."

Thus, he quickly began rinsing her body until there was no more soap left.

After helping her dry her body, Yuan carried Meixiu back to her bed, where he also helped her change into her pajamas.

"After helping you today, I understand the efforts it requires to take care of someone. I won't say that I understand the efforts you and Yu Rou put to take care of me, but I understand that it's not an easy thing to do, yet the both of you make it look so easy."

"Anyways, get some rest, Meixiu. I will be here if you need me." Yuan said to her.

However, when he tried to leave, Meixiu suddenly grabbed his hand.

"What's the matter?" He asked her.

"My body... It's very hot... Help me... Calm it down..." Meixiu said as she stared at him with a charming gaze.

"Calm you down? How do I—"

Meixiu suddenly regained some of her strength and pulled Yuan onto her.

"Yuan... Let's have sex..." she whispered to him.

Yuan's jaw dropped open after hearing her flabbergasting words, and he quickly said, "W-We can't. You have a fever, and you need to rest now."

"I can't rest with a restless body... Just for a while, okay?" Meixiu looked at him with these pleading eyes that could instantly melt even the coldest men

out there.

However, Yuan remained unfazed and sighed, "Just endure it for now. Your body is too weak to do anything right now. Once you have fully recovered, if you still want to, uh... have sex... we can do it for as long as you want..."

"You promise?"

"I promise." He nodded vigorously.

Meixiu didn't say anything else and closed her eyes, quickly falling asleep.

Yuan released a sigh of relief afterward.

He then sat a few meters away from the bed and started to cultivate in silence.

Meixiu woke up a few hours later and said, "Yuan... I'm hungry..."

"I will tell the Qi Family to cook something for you." Yuan said before going outside, where a servant was on standby, and he explained the situation to her.

"I understand. We will have something cooked as soon as possible." The servant bowed to him before running off to find a chief.

Half an hour later, the servant returned with a bowl of rice porridge and handed it to Yuan.

"Can you feed me?" Meixiu asked him.

"Of course." Yuan agreed, and he started spoon feeding her the rice porridge.

Once Meixiu cleared the bowl of rice porridge, she laid back down on the bed and said, "Yuan, can you give me a kiss?"

"...Sure."

He gave her a gentle kiss on the lips.

Despite Meixiu acting a little weird and more demanding than usual, Yuan didn't mind it at all, and he even found it a little bit refreshing. After all, Meixiu was raised to keep everything to herself, and that included her desires, so she rarely asks for anything.

Once Meixiu fell asleep again, Yuan returned to his cultivation.

However, Meixiu wouldn't fully recover until two days later, and during this time, Yuan was the one who took care of her every need, just like how she took care of him when he couldn't move his body.

No matter her request— with a few shameless exceptions that her body wouldn't be able to handle at its condition, Yuan did everything Meixiu wanted with no questions asked.

With this new experience, Yuan learned that he really enjoyed taking care of others, as it made him feel useful in another sense, and he felt that he was finally returning favors to Meixiu, who took care of him when he needed it the most.

Chapter 788 - Do You Want To Do It Now?

"How do you feel?" Yuan asked Meixiu when she woke up on the third day after she collapsed from exhaustion.

"I'm completely fine now. Thank you for taking care of me, and I'm sorry that I kept you from your training sessions. I must have been a burden." Meixiu lowered her head in a shameful manner.

The last time she was even slightly sick was over a decade ago, after all.

"There's no need to apologize. I only took care of you for three short days while you took care of me and my sister for years. If you ask me to continue taking care of you, I would agree, and I wouldn't utter a single complaint."

"What are you going to do now that you've recovered? Continue training?" Chu Liuxiang asked her.

Meixiu looked at Chu Liuxiang and shook her head.

"No, I am going to stay in today. Even though I have recovered, I would like to rest some more."

"That's a good idea. However, I am ready to go back to training. What about you, Yuan? Are you going to resume training?"

Yuan nodded, "Even though I promised the Qi Family that I'd stay for two weeks, things just keep coming up, shortening that time to one week."

Sometime later, Yuan and Chu Liuxiang went to the training area.

"If you need anything, there will be a servant on standby outside." Yuan said to Meixiu before leaving.

Once she was alone, Meixiu returned to her bed, but she didn't go to sleep.

Instead, she got under the blankets and removed her pants and underwear.

"Yuan... You idiot..." Meixiu sighed in a low voice before she started relieving herself.

Meanwhile, when they arrived at the training area, Yuan said to the disciples there, "I apologize for the delay, but I will be resuming my training sessions today."

"For the next two days, we will continue practicing with my killing intent. And for the final few days, we will be sparring with each other just like the first day, but you will also have to endure my killing intent while trying to seal me."

Yuan gave the Qi Family some time to prepare themselves before he took a seat and released his killing intent.

When Qi Man and the other elders heard that Yuan had returned to the training area, they quickly stopped whatever they were doing to participate in the training, as they also benefited greatly from his training.

After three days of break, the Qi Family fully recovered from their fatigue. However, that did not make it any more comfortable for them, as they were still struggling to endure Yuan's killing intent.

At the end of the day, Qi Man approached Yuan and asked him, "How is your lady friend doing?"

"She's recovered, but she didn't join us just in case."

"Well, unlike us, she's in no rush to train." Qi Man said with a smile.

"What do you mean?" Yuan tilted his head in a questioning manner.

"We only have a limited amount of time to train with you, but your friend, on the other hand, will have her entire life to train with you."

Qi Huan suddenly appeared and said, "Why don't you take Qi Fang with you? She may have a problematic personality, but I can guarantee you that she's worth it if you can tame her."

"Tame me? Why are you treating me like I am some sort of animal? I don't need to be 'tamed'!" Qi Fang overheard their conversation and quickly refuted.

"Also, there's no way that I'd ever follow him."

Qi Man turned to look at her and said, "Really? Because I recall how you always mention how you will only follow someone who is stronger than you. If you ask me, I think he's much stronger than you."

Qi Fang opened her mouth, but she couldn't refute his accusations, so she could only close it back up a moment later and feel embarrassed about the whole thing.

"Anyways, I am going to check up on Meixiu. I will see you all tomorrow."

After Yuan and Chu Liuxiang left, Qi Man turned to look at Qi Fang and sighed, "What are you thinking, you silly girl? We were trying to get you a worthy partner."

Qi Fang frowned, "You think I don't know that? It's precisely because I don't want to be his partner that I intervened."

"Why not? He's not only talented but also very young. If you ask me, there's probably nobody out there that's more worthy than him as a partner, especially for families like our Qi Family." Qi Huan said.

"You want me to partner up with my disciples' partner? Just how desperate do you think I am? And even if I was that desperate, I wouldn't do such a thing."

"The young lady from the Chu Family? What makes you think that they're partners? They seem close, but I think he seems closer to Meixiu." Qi Man asked out of curiosity.

"Hmph. He wouldn't fight the entire Chu Family over her if they didn't share a special relationship." Qi Fang snorted.

"Wait... He fought the Chu Family?" They looked baffled by this information.

"Why are you telling us this just now? What happened between Yuan and the Chu Family?"

"It's a long story, and I am tired."

"We have plenty of time."

Qi Fang sighed, "Fine, I will tell you about it, but let me shower real quick first."

Meanwhile, inside Meixiu's room.

"How are you feeling now?" Yuan asked her.

"Bored," she sighed.

"And frustrated."

"What's causing your frustration?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"A lot of things."

"Is there anything I can do to help?"

After a moment of silence, Meixiu responded while staring at him from the bed, "Do you remember your promise?"

"My promise...?" Yuan pondered for a moment before coming to a realization and blushing.

"Y-You mean... I thought that was something you said due to your fever..."

The two of them proceeded to stare at each other in awkward silence.

Eventually, Yuan broke the silence and said, "Do you want to do it now?"

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Chapter 789 - To Make Things Even

"Chu Liuxiang... Where is she?" Meixiu suddenly asked about her whereabouts.

"She returned to her room to shower after training."

Meixiu nodded and continued, "Lock the door first."

After locking the door, Yuan returned to bed.

"What are you waiting for? Take off your clothes." Meixiu said to him as she removed her own clothes.

Yuan swallowed nervously and also removed his clothes.

Even though this isn't their first time doing such a thing, he still couldn't help but feel nervous about it.

Once they were both naked, Meixiu said to him, "Sit over here."

Yuan nodded and got onto the bed.

The next moment, Meixiu moved beside him and rested her head on his shoulders.

"Yuan... Do you hate it when I am like this?" She suddenly asked him.

"Why would I hate you? There's no way that would happen." He quickly replied.

"Even though I am such a pervert? Ever since we did it for the first time, I have been thinking about it nonstop, and every time I look at you, my body gets hotter and would crave for your warmth. I never had such feelings before."

Yuan smiled and said, "To tell you the truth, I have been thinking about it as well."

"Yuan..."

Meixiu tilted her head slightly and kissed him on the lips before adjusting her position.

Once she was ready, she opened her mouth and began sucking Yuan's sword.

A few minutes later, they embraced each other, and their bodies intertwined.

Meixiu moaned softly as she indulged herself with the sensation of Yuan's rod rubbing inside her.

"More... More..."

When Yuan heard Meixiu's charming voice, he felt a rush of adrenaline flow through his body, causing his hips to move faster.

However, after a few minutes of intense thrusting, Yuan suddenly halted his movements when he heard someone trying to open the door.

Yuan immediately used his divine sense to see who it was, and to his surprise, Chu Liuxiang was standing outside of the room with her hand on the doorknob.

"It's Lulu..." He said to Meixiu in a whispering voice.

"I will handle it..." Meixiu nodded.

"Who is it?" She then spoke out loud?

"It's me. I'm here to check up on your condition." Chu Liuxiang said.

"Can you open the door? It's locked."

"Sorry, but can you come back later? I am about to take a bath. Also, I am fine." Meixiu said.

After a moment of silence, Chu Liuxiang continued, "What about Yuan? Do you know where he's gone? I went to look for him at his building, but he didn't appear to be there."

"I'm not sure. Maybe he went to speak with the Elders."

"Okay. Since you're okay, I won't bother you any longer. Enjoy your bath." Chu Liuxiang left right afterward.

Meixiu released a sigh of relief.

"I don't know why, but it feels like we're doing something we're not supposed to... The feeling of not wanting to get caught..." Yuan sighed.

"That's a normal response, especially since we're doing something like this."

"It makes me feel like I am betraying Chu Liuxiang for some reason, and I don't really like this feeling..." Yuan shook his head.

Meixiu stared at Yuan's face that showed genuine concern, and she smiled, "We don't have to hide like this if you don't want to. I will talk to her later."

"Really? That also feels wrong for some reason." Yuan raised his eyebrows.

Meixiu smiled and said, "Well, our relationship is a little special, but we'll get used to it."

"Okay. I will leave it to you." Yuan nodded.

They continued to embrace each other shortly after, and they would not stop until it was almost midnight.

"I'm going to speak with Chu Liuxiang now." Meixiu said to Yuan, who was drying his body with a towel.

"Do you want me to come with you?" He asked.

"No, I think it would be better if I speak to her by myself." Meixiu showed him a beautiful smile before leaving the room.

A few moments later, Meixiu knocked on Chu Liuxiang's door.

"Who is it?"

"It's me. Are you busy right now?"

"No, you can come in. The door's unlocked."

Meixiu entered Chu Liuxiang's room the next moment.

Inside the room, Chu Liuxiang was sitting on her bed in the lotus position. She had been cultivating this entire time.

"Can we talk? There's something that I need to tell you." Meixiu said to her.

Chu Liuxiang smiled and pointed at the chair beside the bed, "Sit down."

Once Meixiu was sitting, Chu Liuxiang spoke, "So, what do you want to talk to me about?"

"It's about Yuan..."

"Yuan? You mean how you're sleeping with him?" Chu Liuxiang said, dropping this massive bomb out of the blue.

Meixiu's eyes widened with shock, and she had this look of total flabbergast on her face.

"H-How did you..."

Chu Liuxiang laughed at Meixiu's response and calmly said, "You know Spirit Masters such as myself have much sharper senses than most people. I could hear you moaning the moment I walked near your room, and I could sense Yuan's presence inside the room with you."

"I pretended that I didn't know anything so that you could enjoy yourselves."

"I'm sorry..." Meixiu sighed.

"Why are you apologizing?" Chu Liuxiang raised her eyebrows.

"You're not angry? I know how much you want to start a family with Yuan, yet I still went ahead and..."

"Angry? Why would I be angry?" Chu Liuxiang became bewildered.

And she continued, "Do you remember the talk we had in the Immortal Caves?"

"I do..." Meixiu nodded.

"Even though I am no longer with the Chu Family, my feelings haven't changed. As long as Yuan is happy and I have a spot in his heart, I don't care how many partners he accepts."

"And to make things even, I have also slept with him, so you don't need to feel guilty." Chu Liuxiang revealed, leaving Meixiu utterly speechless.

"Y-You slept with him? Since when?" Meixiu asked in a dazed voice.

"Just a few days ago.. It was our first time."

Chapter 790 - Sleeping Together

"A few days ago? When he was sick?" Meixiu raised her eyebrows in a puzzling manner.

Chu Liuxiang nodded, "That's right. He was actually looking for you at that time, but you were away, so I stepped in to help. One thing led to another, and our bodies ended up intertwined with each other."

"I had my suspicions already at that time, but I confirmed it today. Anyways, now that we both know the truth, what are you going to do? I don't mind sharing him."

"..."

Meixiu didn't immediately respond, and the hesitation in her eyes were quite clear. Of course, she didn't have any problem with Chu Liuxiang being with Yuan, but she never thought that she would be 'sharing' a man with another woman.

"It's okay if you say no, but just so you know, I won't back down." Chu Liuxiang suddenly said.

"Just think about it. Someone like Yuan, he will never have an ordinary life, and I think that he will only have more partners in the future."

Meixiu sighed, "I know."

"I was trained to be nothing more than a bed warmer for Yuan. Even if I had feelings for him, I would not have a place beside him as an official partner — that's what I had prepared myself for."

"However, all of that changed when we left the Yu Family. I am no longer just a bed warmer, and I can stand beside him not as a mere servant, but as his partner."

She took a deep breath and continued, "If you truly do not mind sharing him, then I also have no problem sharing him. That is my decision."

Chu Liuxiang smiled and extended her hand to Meixiu.

"Then we'll be something like sisters after today."

"Sisters?" Meixiu raised her eyebrow.

"Yes. Since we're both going to be his wife in the future, we might as well treat each other like sisters. That's how my fathers' wives treat each other."

"So, nice to meet you, Sister Meixiu."

Seeing the wide smile on Chu Liuxiang's face, Meixiu couldn't help but smile as well, and she accepted the handshake.

"Let's go see Yuan together." Chu Liuxiang suddenly said.

"Okay."

They went to see Yuan in Meixiu's room shortly after.

"Yuan, we have an announcement to make." Chu Liuxiang said to him.

Yuan swallowed nervously and nodded, "I'm listening."

Chu Liuxiang suddenly grabbed Meixiu's hand and lifted their hands into the air.

"We have come to an agreement that we will both be your partner! Are you okay with that?"

"Both of you as my partners?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

And then he said, "I thought you were already my partners. Why do you need to come to an agreement?"

Chu Liuxiang and Meixiu were left speechless by Yuan's reaction.

"O-Of course we have to come to an agreement! It's not really normal for one person to have multiple wives! If there's no agreement between the wives, it would be a chaotic and toxic family!" Chu Liuxiang explained.

"S-Sorry, I didn't know, and I just assumed everything would be fine..." Yuan sighed.

Due to his inexperience with relationships, he didn't know what was the norm and what was abnormal, not to mention his previous lives' memories, where it's very common for a person to have multiple partners.

Furthermore, everything flowed so naturally that he subconsciously thought everything was fine.

"Well, now you know." Chu Liuxiang said, and she continued, "And if you ever decide to accept more partners, you should consult us first. We need to make sure that she's worthy and won't bring disorder to the family— that's our responsibility as your current partner!"

Yuan nodded, "Okay."

"Good! Then to celebrate this moment, let's all sleep together tonight!" Chu Liuxiang suddenly suggested.

"What?!" Meixiu turned to look at her with wide eyes.

Chu Liuxiang realized what she'd just said and chuckled, "You misunderstood me. I mean we should just sleep on the same bed... normally. I may be okay with sharing him, I don't think I am ready to do that kind of stuff just yet."

"Oh..." Meixiu blushed when she realized her mistake.

"I don't mind." Yuan nodded.

"Then it's decided! We can sleep in this room since we're already here." Chu Liuxiang said.

Sometime later, they got onto the same bed and went to sleep.

Yuan slept in the middle of the bed while Chu Liuxiang and Meixiu slept right beside him on both sides.

"Good night." Yuan said to them.

"Good night." They both said.

The three of them quickly fell asleep.

The following morning, Qi Man looked around the training area but could not see Yuan or the other two.

"Have you seen Yuan? It's already time for training, but he's not here, and the ladies are missing too." He asked Qi Fang and the others, but they all shook their heads.

Of course, Yuan and the others had overslept due to feeling too comfortable from sleeping together.

"Qi Fang, can you go check up on them?" Qi Huan asked her.

"Why me?" She sighed, but she still went to check on their situation.

Qi Fang went to Yuan's living quarter first, but when she saw that his place was empty, she went to Chu Liuxiang's room.

"It's also empty? Where did they go?" Qi Fang frowned, feeling something was off.

She went to Meixiu's room last and subconsciously opened the door without knocking since the last two rooms were empty.

The door wasn't locked, allowing Qi Fang to walk right into Meixiu's room.

And to her absolute shock, Yuan and the other two were sleeping peacefully on the bed. When she witnessed this and realized the situation, her eyes widened and her jaw dropped.

'T-This brat... I am speechless! Turns out that we were both right! He's actually in a relationship with both Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang!' Qi Fang cried inwardly.

'He's so young, yet he's already like this... I cannot imagine what he'll be like in the future when he's all grown up and mature...' She swallowed nervously.

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Chapter 791 - Overslept

Shortly after Qi Fang entered their room, Yuan subconsciously woke up when he sensed a foreign presence within the room.

He immediately used his divine sense, and when he saw Qi Fang standing by the door with a flabbergasted expression, he calmed down.

"S-Senior Qi? What are you doing here?" Yuan sat up on the bed and asked her in an oddly calm voice.

"Do you know what time it is? Everyone is already waiting for you at the training area." Qi Fang said with a frown on her face.

"What? It's already morning? Sorry! I overslept!" Yuan quickly woke up Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang.

"Five more minutes..." Chu Liuxiang mumbled in a low voice.

Meixiu immediately sat up after being woken up, and when she saw Qi Fang standing at the door with her arms crossed, Meixiu's face flushed with redness, and she felt like she had been caught red-handed.

"Lulu, it's Senior Qi! We're late for training!" Yuan tried to wake her up again.

"What?!"

When she heard his words, Chu Liuxiang quickly sat up and turned to look at the door, and sure enough, she could see Qi Fang standing there.

"M-Master!" Chu Liuxiang jumped out of the bed like a startled cat.

"I don't want to hear anything. Just get dressed and head to the training area if you plan on training today." Qi Fang said to them before turning around and walking out of the place.

When she returned to the training area, Qi Man asked her, "What happened? Where's Yuan?"

"Don't worry, he's perfectly fine. He just overslept."

"Overslept? I guess it happens to even the best of us..." Qi Man chuckled.

"By the way, do you remember our talk the other day? About who his partner is?" Qi Fang suddenly asked.

"Yes, what about it?"

"Turns out they were both his partners. They were sleeping together when I found them."

Qi Man and Qi Huan's jaw dropped slightly after hearing this information.

After a moment of silence, Qi Man suddenly started laughing, "What an impressive lad! I should be surprised, but I am actually more impressed! He's earned my admiration! Hahaha!"

Qi Huan shook her head with a smile, "Young people nowadays are sure active. However, a man of his caliber, I am really not surprised."

"What are you going to do now, Qi Fang? This proves that Yuan is willing to accept multiple partners. You can be one of them."

"No way in hell." Qi Fang frowned.

"Don't come complaining to us when it's too late. We're saying this for your own good." Qi Man sighed.

"I won't regret anything. This is my decision."

A few minutes later, Yuan and the other two showed up at the training area.

"Sorry for the delay. I overslept." Yuan apologized to the disciples there.

All of the disciples there were already seated in a circle, so Yuan only needed to get to the center and release his killing intent to begin the training.

A few moments later, Yuan began their training.

His killing intent swept the area and instantly terrorized the people there, and those that were not prepared were immediately eliminated, losing consciousness.

When that happened, the doctors on standby rushed to the scene and grabbed the unconscious disciples out of the zone.

Of course, Yuan purposefully avoided the doctors with his killing intent so that they could assist the disciples. However, even without directly feeling Yuan's killing intent, they could still feel the pressure.

After many hours of training, Yuan retrieved his killing intent and called it a day.

That night, Yuan slept together with Chu Liuxiang and Meixiu again.

The following morning, they made sure to wake up properly, and they made their way to the training area after eating breakfast.

"Today will be the last day of your endurance training. Starting tomorrow, you will be fighting me." Yuan said to the disciples before he started the training.

"Finally, this hellish training is over."

Many of the disciples released a sigh of relief at the end of the day when they realized that they no longer needed to experience Yuan's killing intent ever again.

However, then they realized that they will be fighting against the same monster who releases the killing intent, and that made them nervous again.

The next day, Yuan showed up at the training area with a new appearance that left the disciples dumbfounded.

In order to make the training feel more realistic, Yuan had decided to paint his skin red so that he would look more like a real demon.

"W-What the heck is that? You look ridiculous!" Qi Fang couldn't help but laugh when she saw Yuan's appearance.

Yuan smiled and said, "I know, but I still wanted to try it."

Sometime later, Yuan picked ten disciples to fight him.

"You can use any weapon or technique. You also don't need to worry about hurting me, so give me all you've got."

Once they were prepared, the ten disciples launched their assault on Yuan.

However, when Yuan released his killing intent, the disciples halted their movements and froze on the spot.

"Why are you all just standing there? I had you all endure my killing intent for a reason! Hurry up and attack me! If I was a real demon, you'd all have died the moment you showed even the slightest sign of weakness!" Yuan shouted at the disciples, snapping them out of their daze.

The disciples proceeded to endure Yuan's killing intent and continued their assault on him, but their movements were quite slow and sluggish.

Eventually, Yuan defeated all of the disciples.

"Don't worry, you'll all improve. This is why we're training." Yuan said a few words of encouragement to them before picking ten more disciples to fight.

At the end of the day, only the elders, Chu Liuxiang, Meixiu, and Qi Fang were left.

"All of you can come at me." Yuan said to them.

"A-Are you sure?" Qi Man swallowed nervously.

"I am.." Yuan nodded with a smile.

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Chapter 792 - Magic Trick

Chapter 792: Magic Trick

Once they were ready, all of the elders within the Qi Family along with Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang surrounded Yuan.

In total, there were 25 people that will be participating in this spar, and most of them were Spirit Masters with Meixiu being the only Spirit Warrior.

"Whenever you're ready." Qi Man said to Yuan.

Yuan suddenly lifted his hand, and a large sword appeared out of thin air before falling into his grasp.

This scene shocked everybody there, as they have never seen such a scene before.

"What kind of magic trick did he just do? How did he summon that huge ass sword out of thin air?"

"Is it really a magic trick? I don't know how he did it, but it doesn't look like magic."

The disciples there mumbled to each other Yuan's 'magic trick'.

Of course, the elders were also bewildered by it.

"I wanted to ask you this last time, but how are you doing that?" Qi Fang asked him with a slight frown.

Yuan showed a playful smile and said, "If you defeat me, I will tell you."

"Watch me!"

Qi Fang immediately pounced at Yuan with her sword already swinging towards him.

Ding!

Yuan casually blocked the attack with his Empyrean Overlord, and it felt as though she just struck a block of steel for Qi Fang.

"Don't forget about us!" Qi Man and the other elders suddenly appeared around Yuan to strike him.

Of course, Yuan saw them coming with his divine sense, and he dodged all of their strikes with his movement technique.

Once he dodged the attacks, Yuan released his killing intent, which affected their movements— but not by much.

And for the next few minutes, Yuan would defend and dodge all incoming attacks, and he made it seem so effortlessly.

"Corrupting Blow!" Qi Man suddenly released a devastating strike at Yuan with his sword.

Yuan had no doubt that Qi Man's skill could easily cut through metal like a hot knife in butter just by its sharp aura, but he didn't run away and confronted the attack head-on.

Clang!

A minor shockwave swept the training area when their swords collided, and Qi Man was sent flying back many meters from the backlash.

However, Yuan only moved back a single step, shocking the spectators.

"The disparity in their strength is too huge!"

Suddenly, without even turning his head, Yuan moved his sword beside his head, almost like he was trying to hide behind it.

The next moment, an arrow struck the blade of his sword, and Yuan could feel an immense force behind this seemingly ordinary arrow—one that was even stronger than Qi Man's strike.

After being pushed back a couple of steps, Yuan turned his head towards Meixiu, who was standing many meters away with a bow in her hands, and he smiled.

"No bad! This must be the technique you recently got!" Yuan said as he began moving towards Meixiu.

But before he could get close to Meixiu, Yuan felt an overwhelming force flying towards his direction, causing him to halt and turn around.

Bang!

A massive amount of spiritual energy collided with Yuan's sword, nearly sending him flying.

After stabilizing his body, Yuan turned to look at Chu Liuxiang, who'd just released that powerful attack.

"Are you okay?" Chu Liuxiang asked him afterward.

"Yes, I am." Yuan nodded with a smile.

Out of all of his opponents, Yuan found that Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang were the most annoying with their long range attacks, and when he tried to defeat them first, the other would interfere.

Obviously, he wasn't truly trying to defeat them, or he would have defeated everybody there with a single strike, and that would defeat the purpose of their training.

"I am not done yet!" Qi Fang suddenly appeared behind Yuan and thrust her sword at his back.

However, Yuan had already anticipated her movements and attack, so he shifted his body just enough to dodge Qi Fang's attack before countering

with his empty hand.

"Ah!"

Qi Fang cried out loud when Yuan's fist met her stomach.

An intense pain filled her stomach that quickly spread throughout her body, causing her to kneel on the ground.

"Shit! That freaking hurts! What are you going to do if I cannot have a baby in the future because you punched so damn hard?!" Qi Fang complained.

"Eh?" Yuan's body froze when he heard Qi Fang's words, and he said in an apologetic voice, "S-Sorry, but I didn't use that much strength..."

"No that much strength?! Then you clearly don't know your own strength! You nearly blew a hole in my stomach!" Qi Fang cried.

"Do you need a doctor?" Yuan approached her.

However, when he got close enough, Qi Fang suddenly stood up and attacked him.

"I got you now!"

"Wha—?!"

Because Yuan had lowered his guard, Qi Fang managed to send him flying with a direct hit.

"Damn, that felt great. I have been wanting to hit you for a while now." Qi Fang said with a satisfied look on her face.

When the elders saw Qi Fang's shameless action, they couldn't help but shake their heads.

"Pretending to be hurt and striking when he lowered his guard? That was very shameless and childish of you..." Qi Man sighed, feeling second-hand embarrassment from her act.

Qi Fang coldly snorted, "What are you talking about? He said to defeat him using any means possible. And who said I was pretending? That really hurt! My stomach is in pain even now!"

"She's right, Senior. I had lowered my guard, and she got me. In a fight against demons, you must use any means necessary to win." Yuan said with a calm smile on his face after getting back up and seemingly unscathed. '

"Are you okay? That looked like it hurt." Qi Huan asked him.

"Yes, I am perfectly fine." Yuan nodded.

"Anyways, let's continue."

"Okay."

They continued to spar with each other for another hour until most of the elders were too exhausted to continue.

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Chapter 793 - Their Last Day

"I haven't sweat like this in many years. You have my gratitude, Yuan." Qi Man said to him after the training ended.

"I will see you all back here tomorrow. We'll be doing this until it is time for me to leave." Yuan said.

"Of course. We'll all be here until the last minute."

Once they returned to their room, Meixiu said, "I have rested enough. I need to continue to improve my cultivation."

Yuan nodded, "I also need to practice my Qi Manipulation so that I can fly."

"W-Wait... What? Fly?" Chu Liuxiang looked at him with wide eyes.

Yuan smiled and summoned his Empyrean Overlord, showing them that he could fly with it.

"My god..." The ladies stared at him with shocked expressions on their faces.

"Once you reach Spirit Grandmaster, you'll be able to manipulate your spiritual energy outside your body, allowing you to do things like this." Yuan explained to them.

"Spirit Grandmaster... Wait... You're a Spirit Grandmaster now? Since when?" Chu Liuxiang asked.

"Since I swallowed the demon core."

"Oh, right..."

"Too bad that I will probably never reach Spirit Grandmaster in this world. I don't have your talents, nor do I have the resources."

"Don't lose hope. I'm sure we'll work something out." Yuan said.

"There may not be enough resources in this world, but there are plenty in Cultivation Online. We know that treasures in Cultivation Online also affect us in this world as long as they are strong enough. We've tested this before."

"Once we return home, we'll use the money from Feng Feng to buy treasures to boost our cultivation."

"Okay." Chu Liuxiang nodded.

The following morning, Yuan returned to the training area for another day of training.

This would continue for a few more days until it was time for them to return to the Dragon Spiral Mountain.

"Today will be my last day here, and this is our last training session, so I want you all to give it your all today." Yuan said to the disciples there before starting the training.

At the end of the day, the Qi Family gathered before Yuan.

"Thank you for everything, Yuan." Qi Man bowed to him with clasped hands.

The disciples behind him followed his actions and bowed to Yuan.

"Don't even mention it. The more people that can fight demons out there, the better it is for us." Yuan said with a smile.

"By the way, before we leave, can I take a look at your techniques?" Yuan then asked.

"Of course. I will take you there." Qi Man nodded.

"You guys can go back and pack up. I will be with you later." Yuan said to Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang.

"Okay." They nodded.

Sometime later, Qi Man and Qi Huan brought Yuan to the building where they stored all of their demon sealing techniques.

"It's not much, but..." Qi Man pointed to the small stack of scrolls sitting on top of a desk.

Yuan approached the desk and began reading through the scrolls.

'I already know these techniques from the Demon Sealing Clan's Grand Library...'

Yuan wasn't too surprised by the results since the Demon Sealing Clan created all of these techniques.

"You're done already?" Qi Man asked when he noticed Yuan putting the scrolls back down after glancing at them.

"Yes, I am." Yuan smiled.

"I guess they're really worthless in your eyes, huh?" Qi Huan couldn't help but sigh.

"T-That's not it. I already know these techniques, so there's no point for me to learn them again."

"What? How is that possible? Where did you learn these techniques?"

"Cultivation Online."

Qi Man's eyes widened with shock.

"You mean to tell me that our families' demon sealing technique exists inside a video game?"

"It's more than just a video game— it's what revealed the existence of cultivation to the world."

"It really makes one wonder who on earth created this game and why..." Qi Man mumbled.

"I am trying to search for answers myself. Hopefully, I will get them soon." Yuan said.

As they left the building, Qi Man said, "Anyways, if you need anything else from our Qi Family, we will do our best to assist you. As for the demons in the Dragon Spiral Mountain, we will continue to prolong their seal until we cannot."

"Actually, there is one thing I would like..." Yuan said, and he continued, "Can you give me the locations of all of the demons that your family has found? You said there are dozens out there, right?"

"Do you plan on going to these places and dealing with the demons yourself?" Qi Huan couldn't help but ask.

"No, but it's better to have knowledge than not having any."

Qi Man nodded, "Alright, I will give you a map of their locations. It'll be ready before you leave."

"Thank you."

Sometime later, Yuan returned to Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang.

"We're fully packed. We can leave whenever."

Yuan nodded, and he asked, "Where's the Manager? I haven't seen her since you arrived."

"Now that you mention it, I also haven't seen her." Chu Liuxiang puts on a pondering face.

"The Qi Family should know. I will go ask them."

Yuan left the room shortly after to look for the Qi Family, and he ran into Qi Fang.

"Senior Qi, do you know where the Manager went? I haven't seen her for almost two weeks now." Yuan asked her.

"She's not in any of our guest rooms, so she can only be on the plane," she said.

"The plane? For the last two weeks?" Yuan was speechless.

Qi Fang smiled and said, "You really know nothing about the Manager, huh? She may not look like it, but she's someone who would rather lay around all day and do nothing. Whenever she gets the chance, she will turn into a sloth. She's probably in her room watching television and drinking alcohol from her bed even as we speak."

"I-I understand.. Thank you for the information..." Yuan said.

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Chapter 794 - Leaving The Qi Family

Chapter 794 – Leaving The Qi Family

"By the way, when do you guys plan on leaving?" Qi Fang suddenly asked him.

"We plan on leaving before midnight so that we'd make it home by morning tomorrow."

"Good. The family's preparing a feast for you, so make sure you attend it before you leave. That's all." Qi Fang notified him of a feast before leaving.

Yuan returned to Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang shortly after.

"They're throwing a feast for us, so we'll leave after that." He said to them.

"Un." They nodded.

About two hours later, Qi Fang returned to tell them that the feast was ready.

Yuan and the others followed Qi Fang to this large banquet hall where one side was stacked with tables and chairs and the other side with food.

"What do you think? This is the least we can do for you before you leave." Qi Man approached him with a smile.

"The food looks terrific. I can smell them all the way from here." Yuan smiled.

"You can eat all the food you want. After all, this is your feast." Qi Man laughed.

Yuan wasted no time and immediately grabbed a plate— multiple plates.

Since he could use Qi Manifestation, he used it to carry over a dozen plates of food without lifting a single finger, which shocked everyone that saw it.

"H-How the hell are you doing that?" Qi Fang asked him in a shocked voice.

"Huh? It's Qi Manifestation. You can use it too." Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"What? No I can't."

"But I saw you use it... When we first fought? You used Qi Manifestation to move the sword..."

"Uhh... That sword is a treasure, and it has this unique ability that allows it to fly to me when I call for it. I won't be able to do that with other things, such as plates..." Qi Fang said, leaving Yuan speechless.

"You can't use Qi Manifestation even though you're a Spirit Grandmaster?"

"I have never even heard of Qi Manifestation until today. And even though I am a Spirit Grandmaster, I'd only recently reached this level. It wasn't easy, and it required almost all of our family's resources." Qi Fang explained.

"I see... If you want, I can teach you Qi Manifestation... But at another time." Yuan then said.

"It essentially allows you to manifest and control your spiritual energy outside your body, and you can treat it as though it's another part of your body. It's a really convenient skill. You should learn it."

Qi Fang swallowed nervously after hearing Yuan's words. No doubt, she really wanted to learn Qi Manifestation, especially after seeing what Yuan could achieve with it. There are unlimited possibilities with this ability!

"You promise?"

"Yes, it's a promise."

"Alright. I will be waiting."

Once they were seated, Yuan proceeded to consume all of the food on his plates in a speed that left everyone around him baffled.

"Fuck, is there something that he's not good at? He's even talented in eating!"

"He reminds me of a certain pink and round character in a certain game."

The disciples mumbled to each other as they ate.

A few rowdy hours later, Yuan and the two ladies by his side made their way outside the Qi Family's headquarters, and the entire Qi Family was there to see them off.

"Yuan, here's the map that you requested. It has the location of the demons on it— at least the ones that we— the three families know of."

Yuan nodded and said, "If any of these demons are close to breaking their seal... I want you to let me know immediately."

"Don't worry, you'll be the first one I call when that happens."

"Thank you."

"No, thank you." Qi Man smiled.

"I will escort them to the plane." Qi Fang suddenly said, willingly volunteering to help.

"Oh?" Her grandparents looked at her with funny expressions on their faces.

"You would've told me to do it anyway, right?"

"Who knows." They laughed.

"Let's go." Qi Fang ignored them and said to Yuan's group.

Once they arrived at the plane, Qi Fang said, "Liuxiang, stay behind for a moment."

After Yuan and Meixiu entered the plane to wait for her, Qi Fang spoke, "I have been your master for how long now? Almost 10 years? I was only 16 years old when I started teaching you. At first, I treated you like a little sister, and even as you grew up, my views did not change. I may be strict at times, but they were for your own good."

"You're sounding like we'll never meet again..." Chu Liuxiang looked at her with a questioning gaze.

Qi Fang smiled and said, "You're no longer the immature little girl that I used to know, and you're already a Spirit Master. I don't think I have anything else to teach you— not to mention that you have an even better teacher than me already by your side."

"Y-Yuan? He's not my teacher..."

"I know, he's your partner."

Chu Liuxiang nodded with a slightly rosy face.

Qi Fang's eyebrows twitched upon seeing her reaction.

Then she asked, "H-Have the two of you... already.. you know.. done it?"

Chu Liuxiang's face grew even redder as she nodded her head.

"Looks like you've also surpassed me in some aspects of life..." A bittersweet smile appeared on Qi Fang's face.

"Huh?" Chu Liuxiang looked at her with wide eyes.

"Master, you're still a virgin? How unexpected."

"I-I have a very particular taste in men, and I haven't met the right person yet, okay?! Do you have a problem with that? And don't call me Master anymore! I am letting you go as my disciple!"

Chu Liuxiang smiled and suddenly lowered her head, bowing to Qi Fang, "Thank you for everything, Senior Qi. I also saw you as an elder sister before— I still do even now."

"Take good care of yourself, okay? And you can just call me Sister Fang." Qi Fang smiled.

"You too, Sister Fang. Take care of yourself, and I hope to see you again soon."

The two of them exchanged a quick hug before Chu Liuxiang boarded the plane.

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Chapter 795 - Soon

Chapter 795 – Soon

After entering the plane, Yuan used his divine sense to look for the Manager, and sure enough, just like Qi Fang had said, she was lying on her bed with alcohol in one hand and food in another, and she was watching the television.

Compared to her image at the Dragon Spiral Mountain, she was like a different person.

After snapping out of his surprise, Yuan knocked on her door, which startled her, who was distracted by the television.

"Manager, we're ready to return to the mountain." Yuan said to her.

"I-If you're ready, press the button and fly back already. The plane is fueled up and ready to go." She said to him, not even bothering to leave the bed.

"Okay..."

Once Chu Liuxiang entered the plane, Yuan pressed the red button in the cockpit and started the plane.

"Where's the Manager?" Chu Liuxiang asked once they were in the air.

"She's in her room." Yuan said.

And he continued, "Anyways, we have a couple of hours before we return home. Let's cultivate while we are still in the air. For some reason, the spiritual energy up here is far superior."

"Maybe because it's much purer up here than down there." Chu Liuxiang said.

They began cultivating shortly after until morning came and the plane landed.

"Manager, we've returned home." Yuan knocked on her door when they landed.

A few moments later, she came out of the room looking like a professional businesswoman, and nothing about her could suggest that she was a lazy person.

They all exited the plane, but when Yuan saw the Manager getting into her car, he began having flashbacks of his traumatic experience with her.

"What are you waiting for? Hurry up and get into the car." The Manager said to him when he was the only one standing outside.

Yuan swallowed nervously and entered the front seat.

The moment Yuan felt the car wheels turning, his heartbeat quickened.

However, to his surprise, the car didn't move at the speed of light, and the Manager was actually driving responsibly!

"Are you okay?" Yuan asked the Manager in a worried voice.

She turned to look at him and frowned, "You think there's something wrong with me?"

"Well... You're acting... Weird..." He said.

"Is that so? Then I should probably act normal again, huh?"

"Huh? I don't mean—"

Before Yuan could even finish his sentence, the Manager stepped onto the accelerator all the way, and the car immediately sped up.

"I-I'm sorry if I offended you, Manager! Just slow down!" Yuan exclaimed.

"Too late for that."

And for the remainder of their journey back to the Dragon Spiral Mountain, they continued at maximum speed, which was over 150mph.

Once they reached the mountain, the Manager finally slowed down.

"We're here. You can get out now— except you." The Manager looked at Yuan.

"You guys can go back first and let the others know that we have returned." Yuan said to Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang.

"Okay."

Once they left, the Manager drove Yuan to the peak of the mountain.

"We're going to see the Lord?" Yuan asked.

"What else are we going to do? Watch the scenery?"

Sometime later, they entered the fog on foot until they reached the peak of the mountain.

Yuan approached the cave at the center while the Manager stayed behind and watched from a distance.

"How was the Qi Family? Did you make any new friends?" The Lord's voice resounded from within the cave.

"Yes, I made a lot." Yuan said.

And he continued, "You know... You could've at least told me that I was going to kill a demon for them before sending me there."

"Oh? Did I not tell you? I must have forgotten."

"..." Yuan frowned, and he said, "If I cannot trust you now, why would I trust you in the future— when you tell me about Cultivation Online?"

The Lord remained silent after hearing Yuan's words.

"It was just a test— and you passed it flawlessly."

"Test? What kind of test is that?"

"To see whether you can really kill demons or not, and I wanted to see if you would deal with the demon even though it was not part of our agreement. This shows that you really care about dealing with demons."

"Anyways, now that you have returned... safely. Can you tell me about what happened at the Qi Family?"

Yuan took a deep breath and recalled his experience there.

He spoke about defeating the demon, and he spoke about training the Qi Family.

"Hmm... Interesting..."

"This may seem sudden, but when do you plan on dealing with the demons on the mountain?"

"When...? How am I supposed to know? We don't even know when the demons are breaking out of their seal—"

"It shook." The Lord suddenly interrupted.

"Excuse me?" Yuan raised his eyebrow in a questioning manner.

"The Dragon Spiral Mountain shook three days ago, and the crystal is a lot redder. The demons... They're breaking out of their seals soon."

"Soon...?" Yuan swallowed nervously.

He was confident in handling one demon, but if he had to fight 11 demons at once...

"I really hope you're ready by then." The Lord said.

After a moment of silence, Yuan said, "I will."

"Anyways, if there isn't anything else, I'd like to return home and prepare."

"You may go."

Sometime later, Yuan returned home to find everyone sitting around the diner table.

"Welcome back, Yuan. We've heard everything already from Meixiu." Wang Ming said.

"Not everything." Yuan shook his head.

"What do you mean?"

"The mountain shook three days ago, right? The demons are close to breaking out of their seal, and I will be transferring the demon sealing techniques to you now so that we can prepare."

"Oh? We can finally learn the demon sealing techniques? Nice!"

"Yes. Get in line, I am going to transfer the techniques to you guys now."

Wang Ming and the others quickly got in line to receive their demon sealing techniques.

Chapter 796 - A World Outside The Nine Heavens

Chapter 796 – A World Outside The Nine Heavens

After giving everyone their demon sealing technique, Yuan said to them, "We don't have much time before the demons break out of their seal, so we'll need to prepare ourselves."

"I will begin learning this technique immediately." Wang Ming said.

Everyone returned to their rooms shortly after and began training their demon sealing techniques.

"What are we going to do now, Yuan?" Chu Liuxiang asked him.

"Prepare. I am going to return to the Demon Sealing Clan's Grand Library and learn as much about demons as I can. You two should also prepare."

"Okay." They both nodded.

Yuan entered Cultivation Online while everyone else practiced their demon sealing techniques.

After arriving at the Demon Sealing Clan's Grand Library, Yuan immediately began looking through manuals about demons to see if he could learn any more weaknesses on demons.

However, there wasn't any information that he didn't already know.

"Why are you studying so hard? You're going to stare a hole in that manual at this rate." A voice suddenly resounded behind Yuan as he was completely absorbed in the manual before him.

He turned around to see Yan Hara standing behind him with a smile on her face.

"You could've at least let me know that you were back," she said.

"Sorry, I just got back today, and I am in a bit of a hurry."

"Hurry? What's the rush?"

She glanced at the manual in his hands and mumbled, "Demons?"

"Little founder, are you in trouble... with demons?" She asked him with a frown on her face.

"Well..."

"Where?" Yan Hara's voice suddenly became serious.

"I'm sorry, Senior, but even if I told you, you wouldn't be able to get there. This is a problem that only I can solve."

After a moment of silence, Yan Hara spoke, "Follow me."

"Eh? But—"

"Follow me!" She suddenly shouted, causing everyone there to turn and look at them with intrigued gazes.

"O-Okay..." Yuan placed the manual down and followed Yan Hara to a private room.

After shutting the door, Yan Hara pointed at a chair and said, "Sit down."

"Now, tell me about your demon trouble. I don't understand why you'd want to hide this from me, but I want to help you," she said to him.

"I am telling you, Senior, even if I told you the truth, you wouldn't be able to do anything about it because you won't be able to reach that place with the demons." Yuan sighed.

"Whether I can help or not, I will decide after I hear your explanation."

Yuan sighed, and after a moment of silence, he spoke, "There are some demons that will be breaking out of their seal soon, and I am preparing so that I can deal with them."

"Are you insane?!" Yan Hara suddenly exclaimed, and she looked at him with complete disbelief.

"Little founder! Real demons are nothing like the low-grade artificial demons that you have been fighting! They are a real threat and incredibly dangerous! You cannot try to deal with them by yourself, especially when you're just a Spirit Lord!"

"Tell me the location of these demons and I will alert the Demon Sealing Clan."

"They're in a place called 'Earth'." Yuan calmly responded.

"..."

Yan Hara silently stared at him for a good minute before speaking, "This is not a joking matter, little founder. If we don't deal with these demons soon, it could spell disaster for the Nine Heavens!"

"I am not joking, and the demons are not located in the Nine Heavens." Yuan stared back at her with a serious face.

"W-What the hell do you mean they're not in the Nine Heavens?" Yan Hara frowned.

"Like I'd said, they're on a place called Earth, and this place doesn't belong in the Nine Heavens."

"And I am well aware of how dangerous demons can be. After all, I have already encountered a few of them."

Yan Hara's eyes widened with shock after hearing Yuan's confession.

"You... Just who are you, little founder?" She asked him in a low voice.

"You wouldn't believe me even if I told you..." He sighed.

"This place... If it's not within the Nine Heavens, then it can only be a realm that exists outside of the Nine Heavens. I have always heard rumors that such places exist, but there has never been concrete proof. You... You came from outside the Nine Heavens?"

Yuan smiled upon hearing her somewhat accurate deduction.

"Something like that," he shrugged.

"Unbelievable..." Yan Hara muttered in a flabbergasted voice.

"Now you understand why you— nor the Demon Sealing Clan could help me, right? I know you're worried, but it's okay, it's not my first time fighting— even killing a demon."

"..."

After another long moment of silence, Yan Hara asked, "How... How many demons have you encountered...and killed so far?"

Yuan pondered for a moment to count.

"Uhhh... Six demons?"

He'd killed four in the Mystic Realm, one in the Jaded Garden, and one in the Qi Family.

"S-Six... demons...?" Yan Hara repeated in a dazed voice.

'He's killed even more demons than me?! How is that possible?! He's only a Spirit Lord!' She cried inwardly.

She did not want to believe Yuan, but she couldn't see any lies within his clear eyes.

"I know six sounds like a lot, but it's really not, considering how there are dozens of sealed demons that are about to break out of their seals in that world..." Yuan sighed.

"Dozens of sealed demons? Just what kind of world is that? It sounds so ridiculous..." Yan Hara sighed.

"And six demons is a lot! Do you know how many demons the average demon sealers kill?! Zero! Freaking zero! I am one of the top demon sealers in my generation, and I have only killed three demons, which is already considered a freaking miracle! Of course, this is mostly because demons are pretty much extinct... If not for that fact, I would have killed many more demons..." Yuan Hara sighed, trying to justify her low kill count compared to his.

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Chapter 797 - Demons' Ranking

Chapter 797 – Demons' Ranking

"Anyways, since the Demon Sealing Clan cannot help you with your demon problem, you'll have to deal with it yourself. Since you're already an expert at killing demons and the future Divine Paragon, I'm sure you'll do fine..." Yan Hara said.

Yuan raised his eyebrows. Just a moment ago, she was telling him how dangerous demons are and that he won't be able to handle them by himself, yet after learning that he'd killed twice as many demons as her, she has suddenly become supportive and even confident in his abilities.

"How confident are you?" She suddenly asked him.

"Not that confident. I won't know the demons' strength until they break out of their seal, and that is my biggest worry. What if I cannot handle the demon? What if the demon is much stronger than me?" Yuan sighed.

"Well... Fortunately, most demons that just break out of their seal are at their weakest state, and it would take them days to weeks to recover their strength." Yan Hara said.

"Do you have any suggestions on how I should prepare?" Yuan then asked.

"Since you've already killed 6 demons, you can continue doing whatever you were doing, as it clearly works. Also, I know of a way for you to check a demons' strength even if they are sealed."

"Really? How?" Yuan's eyes immediately began flickering with excitement.

"Come with me."

Yan Hara opened the door and walked him to the open area with the artificial demons.

Once there was an available spot, Yan Hara took it and sealed the artificial demon before it could even move.

"Put your hand on this sealed demon and use your spiritual energy to penetrate the seal to analyze the demon's strength."

"But won't that risk unsealing the demon?"

"It'll be fine. If you could unseal a demon so easily, the Demon Sealing Clan would be a laughing stock. Only demon sealing aura could unseal a demon," she said.

Yuan nodded and approached the demon before putting his hands on it, feeling its stone-like texture.

He closed his eyes next and used his spiritual energy to penetrate through the seal to check the artificial demon, and sure enough, he could not only sense the demons' cultivation, he could also sense its heartbeat and blood flow.

"It works! I can sense their strength! This is great! Thank you, Senior!" Yuan said to her with a bright smile.

She nodded with a slightly rosy face, and she spoke, "Do you have any other questions?"

Yuan pondered for a minute before nodding, "How can I tell the difference between a low-rank demon and a superior demon? And I would like to learn more about demon ranking in general."

Yan Hara nodded, "Alright. Let's go to the library then."

Sometime later, Yuan sat down in the library while Yan Hara went to fetch a couple of manuals.

When Yan Hara returned, she placed the manuals on the table and began lecturing him about demons.

"There are six ranks of demons. From the lowest— Lower Demon, Elite Demon, Superior Demon, Demon General, Demon Emperor, and Ancient Demon. You can judge a demon's rank by their appearance. Higher ranking demons will have more unique features and abilities. Their crystals will also be slightly different from each other."

"Lower Demons and Elite Demons will have a red crystal somewhere on their body while Superior Demons will have a black crystal. However, Demon Generals and above do not reveal their crystal so openly, so if you see a demon without their crystal on the outside, there's a very good chance that they are a Demon Emperor— or even stronger."

"Something else that differentiates them is their control. A higher ranking demon can control their emotions and rage much better than those inferior, so they are usually calmer and not as easy to provoke. However, once provoked, they will be multiple times stronger than usual. If you're fighting against a Demon General or above, your best chance is to defeat them without provoking them, and you should never openly provoke a demon, as that would only fuel their powers even further."

Yuan began sweating cold sweat after hearing Yan Hara's advice to not provoke them, as that's what he has been doing to the demons that he fought. He never thought that he was actually making them harder to fight by provoking them.

"Instead of provoking demons, you should make them scared of you. That is your number one priority. Once a demon fears you, they will no longer be a threat. That's why the Divine Paragon was undefeated, as all demons feared him to some extent."

"Make them fear me, huh..." Yuan nodded with a serious expression.

"Here are a few examples of demons at each rank." Yan Hara gave him another manual, but there were mostly pictures on this manual.

"Lower Demons look pretty ordinary. Red skin and horns, and they are usually the size of an adult human. Elite Demons to Demon Generals would have special features, such as being larger than normal, having a third eye, having wings, and much more. However, Demon Emperors and above—they can actually lack demon characteristics."

"Huh? What do you mean by that?" Yuan asked.

"It means that they can appear more like humans than actual demons. There have been demons that did not have their signature red skin and horns. Some demons in the past even looked exactly like humans. Rumor has it that these demons still live amongst us humans even today."

Yuan was left speechless by this information. Demons that look exactly like humans? Then how are they supposed to tell the difference?

Yan Hara smiled and said, "I know what you're thinking, but the chance of that actually happening is very slim. Even if there are demons living amongst us, they won't do anything stupid to reveal themselves, and with the Demonic Realm sealed, they are powerless."

"Although humans were dominated by demons back then, things have changed. We're no longer as weak and vulnerable as our ancestors.. We have the knowledge and techniques to fight back against them if they ever dare to return."

Chapter 798 - Demon Sealing Pagoda

Chapter 798 – Demon Sealing Pagoda

"Thank you for the lecture, Senior. I learned a lot about demons today."
Yuan bowed to her at the end of their lecture.

"We're not done yet." Yan Hara suddenly said.

"Huh?" Yuan tilted his head in a questioning manner.

"Come with me. I'm going to make sure that you're fully prepared to fight the demons."

Yan Hara then brought Yuan to this tall pagoda.

"What is this place?" He asked her.

"Demon Sealing Pagoda. You will get to fight real demons inside... Well, sort of."

"What do you mean by that? They're either real demons or not..."

"They are demons created with spiritual energy, so they're not really real, but they act exactly like real demons, and even their power level is the same, so it'll be like fighting against real demons inside."

"This treasure was created by the Divine Paragon, and it was used to train the Demon Sealing Clan back in the days, but it requires a massive amount of spiritual energy to use, so we eventually stopped using it and started training with artificial demons, which is cheaper."

"Another reason we stopped using the treasure is because of its difficulty. Most demon sealers nowadays won't be able to pass the first floor, and there are nine total floors. For the record, I got all the way up to the fourth floor."

"And you want me to train in this pagoda? Are you sure? It's expensive to use, right?" Yuan looked at her.

"One of many perks of being a lecturer in this place is that we get to use the pagoda for free once every 10 years. Of course, it's not really free, since it'll be at the library's expense." Yan Hara smiled.

"What do you think? You wanna give it a go? Rumor has it that if you manage to defeat the tower, you'll get to acquire a legendary demon sealing technique that only the Divine Paragon knows."

"A legendary demon sealing technique?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

If that is true, he will be able to acquire this technique even without challenging the pagoda. After all, he was the Divine Paragon!

However, he still nodded his head, "Yes, I would like to challenge the tower."

In the end, he still needed practice. Even if he's the reincarnation of the Divine Paragon, it was not as though he has all of his previous memories and experiences.

"Alright, give me some time to prepare. I also need to let the library know that I will be using the pagoda."

"Okay."

About half an hour later, Yan Hara returned to the pagoda and said, "Whenever you're ready."

"I am ready."

Yan Hara then retrieved a golden key and used it to unlock the doors to the pagoda.

"You will get the rules once you are inside. The demons inside will be adjusted to match your power level, so you don't need to worry about being

overwhelmed by a demon that you cannot defeat. However, this also means that you won't be able to dominate the demons like you normally do."

"I understand." Yuan nodded, and he opened the door.

The moment Yuan entered the pagoda, the door slammed shut, and the pagoda suddenly started trembling with excitement.

"W-What is going on? This has never happened before..." Yan Hara muttered in a dazed voice.

Suddenly, an outburst of demon sealing aura exploded from the Demon Sealing Pagoda, sweeping the Grand Library with a massive amount of demon sealing aura.

When the demon sealers within the Grand Library felt this ancient and unfathomable demon sealing aura, their bodies began trembling nonstop, almost as though it was reacting to the demon sealing aura.

"W-Whose demon sealing aura does this belong to?! I have never felt such a powerful demon sealing aura in my life!" The lecturers within the Grand Library were shocked speechless by this phenomenon.

The entire Grand Library became nervous when this unknown demon sealing aura filled the place. Their initial thought was that a peak demon sealer had appeared within the Grand Library, so they immediately began looking around for the source of this demon sealing aura.

Meanwhile, back at the Demon Sealing Pagoda, Yan Hara was staring at the top of the pagoda with a dazed look on her face for some reason.

"D-Divine Paragon...?" She muttered in a low voice.

After the powerful demon sealing aura exploded from the pagoda, she noticed a figure had suddenly appeared on top of the pagoda, causing her to look.

And to her absolute shock, there was a person hovering directly above the pagoda, and he looked awfully like Yuan, but he was much older and had

this irresistible charm around him.

"I-Impossible... This must be an illusion caused by the Demon Sealing Pagoda, but why...?"

"D-Divine Paragon?! Is that really you?!" Yan Hara spoke to him after snapping out of her daze.

The Divine Paragon suddenly looked down at Yan Hara and showed her a gentle smile before looking down at the pagoda that was right beneath him with a profound expression on his face.

Yan Hara's heart nearly exploded into countless pieces from excitement when she saw the Divine Paragon's smile that was directed at her, and it felt like a dream.

Eventually, more people began appearing at the Demon Sealing Pagoda after tracking the demon sealing aura.

Of course, everyone that saw the Divine Paragon was shocked speechless at first.

"Y-Yan Hara! What's going on here?! Why is... Why is the Divine Paragon here?!" Tang Zheng asked her after he arrived.

"I-I have no idea. He suddenly showed up after Yuan entered the Demon Sealing Pagoda..." Yan Hara explained.

"Yuan?" Tang Zheng turned to look at the pagoda.

"What in heavens' name is happening?"

Meanwhile, inside the pagoda, Yuan was currently being told the rules of the pagoda.

Of course, the voice belonged to the Divine Paragon.

"Welcome to the Demon Sealing Pagoda, young demon sealer. I will now tell you the rules of this place.. If you break any of them, you'll

automatically be casted out of this place."

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Chapter 799 - Superior Demon

Chapter 799 – Superior Demon

"First rule, you must defeat the demon before you to challenge the next floor."

A demon suddenly appeared on the opposite side of the room.

Yuan's eyes widened with shock when he saw that it had a black crystal embedded within chest.

"A Superior Demon? Are you kidding me?" He muttered in a voice of disbelief.

"Second rule, you will have an hour to seal or kill the demon. Failure to do so will result in getting kicked out."

"Third rule, you cannot die while inside the Demon Sealing Pagoda. If you 'die' inside, you will be transported outside safely, but you will not be able to use the Demon Sealing Pagoda for 30 days."

"When you're prepared to start the challenge, say 'Ready' out loud."

Yuan closed his eyes and took a deep breath.

He then summoned the Empyrean Overlord and the Starry Abyss.

"Ready."

Whoosh!

The scenery suddenly changes, turning the place into an empty and spacious field.

Yuan looked around with a surprised face. Did he get teleported, or was this simply an illusion?

However, he didn't have much time to think, as the demon started attacking him the moment the scenery changed.

Yuan commanded the Starry Abyss to distract the demon, but to his surprise, the demon could sense the invisible Starry Abyss and dodge it perfectly.

'It's not only a Superior Demon, but it's also a Spirit King?! Is this demon really 'equal' to my strength?!' Yuan cried inwardly.

"Bloody Daggers!"

The demon suddenly summoned two crimson daggers using its blood, wielding it like some sort of edgy assassin.

Whoosh!

The demon kicked its legs and propelled forward like a bullet, shooting straight at Yuan at a ridiculous speed.

The demon closed their distance almost instantly, but Yuan was able to barely react and block the strike.

Boom!

Yuan was sent flying from the impact.

After quickly stabilizing himself, Yuan looked at his arms that were still shaking, and it felt like he'd been struck by a truck— as an ordinary human.

'This is freaking ridiculous... I need to focus on the fight, or I will not pass the first floor!'

Yuan quickly cleared his mind and focused on the demon with the obnoxious black crystal on its body.

"Haaa!"

The two of them clashed with each other shortly after, and every time their weapons collided, the world there would seemingly shake a little.

Boom! Bang! Clang!

They went at each other's throat like animals that have been starving for days, and Yuan used all of his techniques against the demon.

[Heavenly Domain!]

Holy pressure suddenly bore down on the demon, but it barely affected its movements if any at all.

Seeing that his Heavenly Domain didn't work on the demon, Yuan used Dragon's Gaze when the time was right.

[Dragon's Gaze!]

His eyes began emitting a golden glow that instantly stunned the demon.

However, he knew that it wouldn't keep the demon stunned for long, so he quickly used this moment to attack the demon with the Demon Sealing Strike.

Normally, he only needed to hit the demon once for it to be sealed, but Yuan didn't want to take any chances, so he continued to swing his sword until he could no longer swing it.

Yuan had managed to strike the demon 12 times with the Demon Sealing Strike before the demon snapped out of its daze, but by that time, half of its body was already petrified.

'Looks like I made the right decision by not stopping...' Yuan sighed inwardly when he saw that the demon was still only half sealed despite getting struck 12 times by his powerful demon sealing technique.

Compared to the Elite Demon, this Superior Demon was far stronger— it was simply in a league of its own, and it took Yuan all of his efforts just to defeat it.

"Congratulations, you have managed to pass the first floor in... 6 minutes. It's a new record." The Divine Paragon's voice resounded shortly after he sealed the demon, and Yuan was sent back to the pagoda.

"Here is your reward for clearing the first floor."

A golden orb of light suddenly emerged from the wall of the pagoda and floated towards Yuan.

Yuan extended his hands and accepted the golden orb of light.

The moment the light touched his palms, it entered his body and disappeared.

Yuan suddenly felt an outburst of spiritual energy within his Dantian, instantly raising his cultivation by two levels, reaching Fourth Level Spirit Lord.

Furthermore, all of his fatigue disappeared, and he felt completely refreshed.

"You may proceed onto the next floor whenever you're ready."

Yuan proceeded onto the second floor through the staircase at the corner of the room.

"Welcome to the second floor. You have one hour and thirty minutes to defeat the demon."

Another demon materialized in the pagoda, but there was something different about this demon.

The demon did not emit the power of a Spirit King. In fact, its cultivation had been lowered to Spirit Lord.

However, that was not the only change.

"This demon... It doesn't have a crystal on its body... This could only mean... Demon General..."

"The pagoda reduced its cultivation but increased its rank? It will most likely be as strong as the Superior Demon in terms of raw strength, but it will also have more techniques and tricks up its sleeves."

"When you're prepared to start the challenge, say 'Ready' out loud." The Divine Paragon's voice resounded.

"Ready!" Yuan shouted out loud once he prepared himself.

The scenery changed again. However, they were no longer in an empty field. Instead, they appeared to be on a platform inside a coliseum, and there were even spectators.

"Kill that demon!"

"Kill it!"

The crowd cheered with excitement, their voices filled with passion and anger, causing Yuan's heart to tremble.

Chapter 800 - Demon General

Chapter 800 – Demon General

"Kill it! Kill it! Kill it!"

The crowds' cheering was so loud that it shook the platform Yuan was standing on, and he swallowed nervously.

"What a rowdy bunch... Don't you agree, human?" A cold voice suddenly resounded.

Yuan turned to look at the demon that'd just spoken.

'They can speak? The last one remained silent for the whole fight...' Yuan thought to himself.

"Are you a mute or something?" The demon raised its eyebrows at Yuan when he didn't respond.

"If I wanted to have a conversation with a demon, I wouldn't be here."

"Fair enough." The demon smiled at Yuan's words.

Yuan suddenly felt a chill run down his spine, and he instinctively raised the Empyrean Overlord over his head.

The very next second, Yuan could feel something heavy slamming into his sword. It was so sudden that it actually brought Yuan to his knees.

"W-What the hell is going on?" Yuan was baffled by the situation.

He could still see the demon standing on the other side of the platform, and there was nothing in front or around him, so what is the demon using to attack him?

'If I cannot see it with my bare eyes, then I have to use my divine sense!'

Yuan quickly activated his divine sense, and sure enough, he could see a translucent claw on top of him.

'This is... Qi Manifestation!'

He immediately recognized what the demon was doing, but he was still surprised by it.

The demon was only a Spirit Lord just like him, but its Qi Manifestation was multiple times stronger than his own.

"Ha!"

Yuan eventually stood back up and swung his sword, destroying the demon's Qi Manifestation.

However, the moment Yuan destroyed the invisible claw, the demon summoned another one— then another.

Boom!

Yuan used his movement technique to dodge the claws.

'Demons basically have unlimited spiritual energy, so it will be able to continue attacking me until I run out of spiritual energy. I need to think of something...'

Yuan pondered for a strategy as he continued to dodge the demon's invisible attacks.

As for the Demon General, it was just standing at the edge of the platform with a calm smile on its face, clearly not planning on dirtying its own hand.

Suddenly, an outburst of demon sealing aura exploded from Yuan's body, creating a profound ripple that swept the platform.

When the ripple touched the Demon General's spiritual energy, it immediately dispersed like smoke.

"Not bad." The Demon General said.

"I am not finished!"

Yuan quickly gathered as much spiritual energy as he could within a second before releasing the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike at the demon.

When the Demon General saw the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike, its initial thought was to just block it with its body, since it could just recover.

However, it suddenly sensed a dreadful feeling coming from the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike, forcing it to move from its spot to dodge the strike.

The Heaven Splitting Sword Strike barely missed the Demon General and crashed into the spectators' area, killing thousands of spectators.

Of course, since this was just an illusion, the destroyed areas would restore itself, and the dead spectators would come back to life a few moments later.

After dodging the Heaven Spitting Sword Strike, the Demon General looked at Yuan with a look of surprise on its face.

"You... imbued your demon sealing aura into another technique? Are you really just a Spirit Lord?"

Right before he released the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike, Yuan infused some of his demon sealing aura into the technique, which essentially turned the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike into a demon sealing technique!

However, this is a technique that only high-ranking demon sealers learn and not something a mere Advance Demon Sealer could achieve.

'I-It actually worked?' Yuan was as surprised as the Demon General, as he was only testing his theory.

He figured that if demon sealing aura is what really harms demons, he could probably enhance his regular techniques with his demon sealing aura, making them demon sealing techniques. This could essentially turn any technique out there into a demon sealing technique.

However, Yuan was unaware that in order to achieve such a feat, one would normally have to train for hundreds of years and the reason he was able to do it was due to his past experience.

"Hahaha! Things are finally starting to get interesting! Entertain me some more, human!" The Demon General laughed in a chilling manner.

[Heavenly Domain!]

Yuan activated Heavenly Domain when the demon started running at him.

The Demon General's movement suddenly became sluggish, as Yuan had enhanced the Heavenly Domain with his demon sealing aura.

"Not bad! Not bad at all! However, you'll need much more than that if you want to defeat me, a Demon General!"

[Ten Thousand Ghost Blades!]

Yuan activated his newfound technique, cloning the Starry Abyss until there were a thousand of them.

The Demon General was at a loss for words when it was suddenly surrounded by a thousand daggers that looked identical to each other.

"Go!"

Yuan flicked his sleeves, commanding the thousand-strong army of Starry Abyss to rain down upon the Demon General.

Of course, these Starry Abyss had all been imbued with his demon sealing aura, so each of these daggers was akin to a demon sealing technique.

The Demon General wanted to run, but there was nowhere to run, so it could only defend the attack head-on.

The Demon General used its Qi Manifestation and body to deflect the Starry Abyss.

Although it managed to destroy a few dozen Starry Abyss, the Demon General eventually became overwhelmed, especially since Yuan could always make more.

"AAAAAH!"

The Demon General released a deafening roar when it realized that it could not defeat Yuan's thousand Starry Abyss, and the very next moment, a thousand holes opened up in the Demon General's body, looking like a porcupine with a thousand daggers stabbed into its body.

"Congratulations, you have managed to pass the second floor in... 13 minutes. It's a new record.." The Divine Paragon's voice resounded a moment later.

Chapter 801

Chapter 801 – Quick Breakthroughs

"Here is your reward for clearing the second stage."

The golden orb of light returned, and Yuan quickly absorbed the spiritual energy from it.

His cultivation immediately had a breakthrough, reaching the Seventh Level Spirit Lord from the Fourth Level Spirit Lord.

'I'm already at the Seventh Level of Spirit Lord after passing two floors, and there are still 7 more floors to go... This place is extremely good for raising one's cultivation base very quickly.' Yuan wondered what his cultivation level would be at the end of all this.

Sometime later, Yuan climbed to the third floor.

"Welcome to the third floor. You have one hour to defeat the demons." The Divine Paragon's voice resounded.

"Wait... Demons?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

Suddenly, two figures appeared before him. Of course, they were demons, and they were both Demon Generals with a cultivation of Spirit Lord.

"Heavens... I have to fight two of them at once now?" Yuan swallowed nervously.

"When you're prepared to start the challenge, say 'Ready' out loud." The Divine Paragon's voice resounded again.

Yuan didn't immediately start the challenge and took a moment to mentally prepare himself.

This will be his first time fighting two demons at once by himself.

After taking a deep breath, he spoke, "Ready!"

The very next moment, the two Demon Generals rushed at Yuan, attacking him from two different directions.

[Ten Thousand Ghost Blades!]

Yuan summoned one thousand copies of his Starry Abyss and used those to deal with one of the demons while he personally fought the other demon with the Emyrean Overlord.

One would expect Yuan to dominate these demons because of his increased cultivation, but the pagoda increased the strength of the demon to match his strength, so it was just as difficult.

Fortunately, Yuan had learned how to infuse his demon sealing aura with his ordinary techniques, allowing him to fight the demons with more ease.

Even though the demons match his strength, that doesn't necessarily mean they're equal, as one's technique and treasures can easily affect the balance.

Of course, the Demon Sealing Pagoda also took into account his treasures and techniques, but there is only so much it can gauge, and when it comes to an unfathomable genius like Yuan, not even it could fully measure his full potential.

[Demon Sealing Sword Strike!]

Yuan swung the Emyrean Overlord at the demon, but it easily blocked it with its weapon made out of blood.

After blocking the attack, the demon tossed the weapon away since it would be sealed by the demon sealing aura.

As for the other demon, it was slowly getting sealed by the Starry Abyss.

Although each of the Starry Abyss lacked the demon sealing aura to seal a demon with one strike, they could easily strike the demon multiple times before it could even react, slowly sealing it.

After thirty minutes of fighting back and forth, Yuan eventually managed to seal one of the demons.

"A mere human! How dare you!"

The demon roared, and its body began burning red, almost as though its blood had turned to lava. Its body also grew larger, but not by much.

BOOM!

The demon suddenly disappeared from its position, appearing in front of Yuan before throwing a powerful punch at him.

This time, Yuan was unable to react fast enough, and he was hit square in the chest by the demon.

Whoosh!

Yuan's body flew backward like a broken ragdoll, landing many meters away.

'Shit... Even with all of my defenses, it still hurts like hell!' He cried inwardly as he quickly stood back up.

If it weren't for the Invisible Dragon Cloak that doubled his defense stats, his body would've probably exploded into a bloody mess.

Furthermore, even though the demon was only a Spirit Lord, it'd managed to penetrate the Invisible Dragon Cloak's defense that blocks all damage from those below Spirit King. Though, this is most likely because the Demon General's true strength far surpasses a Spirit King, allowing it to bypass the armor's effects.

"I am impressed that you survived, human. What is your body made out of? Treasures?" The Demon General slowly approached him with a malicious

grin on its face.

After standing back up, Yuan spat out some blood, but his expression remained unfazed.

[Ten Thousand Ghost Blades!]

Yuan activated his most powerful technique again, sending 1,000 Starry Abyss at the Demon General.

However, the Demon General merely stood there and allowed the daggers to hit its body.

'What?!' Yuan exclaimed inwardly when the daggers shattered on impact while the Demon General appeared to be completely fine.

The Demon General, without even looking at its body, smiled and said, "You'll need to do better than that if you want to penetrate my defense."

Yuan frowned as he could feel a sense of dread from this Demon General that was clearly stronger than the other Demon General.

"Come, entertain me some more, human!"

The Demon General continued to approach Yuan.

Seeing this, Yuan commanded the rest of the Starry Abyss to attack the Demon General even if it might seem pointless.

"It's useless! Hahaha!" The Demon General roared with laughter.

Yuan tried to focus all of the Starry Abyss on a single location, hoping that he'd slowly break through the Demon General's defense, but it was useless.

The Demon General suddenly leaped forward and swung its blood weapon, clashing with Yuan's Empyrean Overlord.

"Give up! You're just a mere human! Humans are born to serve demons! There is no way humans can ever defeat demons!" The Demon General

provoked Yuan as they swung their weapons at each other, causing the surrounding space to shake with every swing.

"If that was true, you demons wouldn't be facing extinction right now!" Yuan clapped back at the demon, leaving it speechless for a moment.

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Chapter 802

Chapter 802 – Assistance

"Thirty minutes left." The Divine Paragon's voice resounded once Yuan used up half of his time on the third floor.

"Haaa... haaa..." Yuan breathed heavily, his body covered in sweat.

This is the first time that anyone has been able to compete against him so perfectly.

No matter what he did, the Demon General would always have a response to it.

It was at this moment Feng Yuxiang's voice resounded, "Young Master, would you like some assistance?"

"Huh?" Yuan responded in a dumbfounded voice as he continued to block the Demon General's attacks.

He was so absorbed in his situation that he'd completely forgotten about their existence!

"What do you mean by help?"

"Well... I am your servant... If you wish, I can help you fight this demon. Of course, I won't be able to defeat it for you since I do not have the capability, but I can definitely stall it for you."

"Can you even do that? Won't that be cheating?" Yuan asked.

"Young Master, do you truly know the relationship between a servant and master? You, Young Master, own our body and soul the moment we sign the servant contract. In other words, we are your possession. Therefore, we

are no different than the Soul Weapons that you have been using this entire time."

"What?!" Yuan was left speechless by this information.

This entire time, he could've had his servants help him?

"I-If that's the case, why couldn't you help me during the Stairway to Heaven?"

"The Stairway to Heaven is a special place with special rules. This pagoda, however, doesn't appear to have such rules. There are no forces that prevents me from helping you— at least I don't feel them. And the fact that we were allowed to enter this place with you only further confirms it."

After pondering for a moment, Yuan said, "Please help me distract the demon while I prepare for my attack!"

The next second, Feng Yuxiang came out of his body and flicked her sleeves, instantly engulfing the Demon General in flames.

However, she was not the only one who appeared, as Xiao Hua also decided to show up. She clearly didn't want Feng Yuxiang to get all of the spotlight.

"Xiao Hua will help Brother Yuan as well," she said.

"O-Okay..." Yuan nodded.

"Sorry, Yuan, but I most likely won't be of any help even if I come out." Lan Yingying said to him.

She was only a Spirit Grandmaster, so she will most likely only hinder them instead of helping.

"It's okay, Yingying. We got this."

"Hahaha! What a surprise! This flame— Phoenix's flame! I have never tasted Phoenix blood before!" The Demon General laughed out loud even as its body was still engulfed in flames.

"Distract it for me, I will prepare the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike." Yuan said to them.

"Understood!"

Feng Yuxiang's black hair suddenly turned red, and her eyes glowed golden.

Meanwhile, Xiao Hua's cultivation base exploded forward.

'This is my first time seeing Xiao Hua use all of her strength...' Yuan thought to himself as Xiao Hua summoned a huge sword.

Even though she couldn't use Sword Qi, she could still wield the sword better than many Swordmasters.

While the Demon General was still covered in flames, Xiao Hua kicked her small feet and flew towards the demon without hesitation before swinging her sword, sending a massive sword light made out of spiritual energy at the demon.

Whoosh!

The sword light shattered the moment it struck the demon, but the demon wasn't unscathed either, as it clearly sustained some damage.

However, Xiao Hua didn't stop there and released a quick Heaven Splitting Sword Strike at the demon.

The ground shook as a massive beam of light swallowed the demon.

Although Yuan is stronger than Xiao Hua overall, he actually lagged behind Xiao Hua in terms of techniques, especially when it came to the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike.

The Heaven Splitting Sword Strike managed to destroy half of the Demon General, but it quickly began recovering.

It was at this moment that Feng Yuxiang released her technique.

"Burn in hell!"

With the flick of her sleeves, Feng Yuxiang summoned a large Phoenix created from her flames, sending it flying at the demon.

The heat from the flames were so intense that it slowed the demon's recovery, as the flames would quickly destroy the demon almost as quickly as it healed.

"I am ready!"

It was at this moment that Yuan started swinging the Empyrean Overlord.

When Xiao Hua and Feng Yuxiang heard his voice, they returned to his body.

The following second, Yuan released his Heavenly Splitting Sword Strike.

Whoosh!

Everything in front of Yuan was immediately erased from existence—including the Demon General.

"Congratulations, you have passed the third floor... in 38 minutes." The Divine Paragon's voice resounded shortly after.

"Thank you, Feng Feng and Xiao Hua. I might not have defeated the Demon General by myself if you didn't help." Yuan said to them afterward.

"Young Master, we are your weapons and shield. You don't thank your weapons every time you use them, right?"

Yuan smiled, "Maybe I should. And don't lower yourself like that. You may be my servants, but you're also my valuable companions. I would never treat you like a tool."

Sometime later, the golden orb appeared before Yuan, allowing him to absorb all of its spiritual energy.

Ding!

"Ninth Level... I will be able to enter Spirit King once I pass the next floor..." Yuan mumbled to himself.

It's only been an hour since he entered the Demon Sealing Pagoda and he's already increased his cultivation by almost an entire realm.

He could only imagine how far his cultivation base will go after he finishes all nine floors!

However, with the increase in difficulty after every floor, he was a little worried about the future floors.

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Chapter 803 - Experiencing Death

After clearing the third floor, Yuan proceeded to make his way to the fourth floor of the Demon Sealing Pagoda.

'I had to fight two demons at once on the last floor. Will I need to fight three at once this time?' He wondered to himself as he walked the staircase.

Upon entering the fourth floor, Yuan waited for the Divine Paragon's voice to resound.

"Welcome to the fourth floor. You have fifteen minutes to defeat the demon." The Divine Paragon's voice resounded a moment later.

"Only fifteen minutes?" Yuan exclaimed. He did not expect such drastic changes, going from having an hour to defeat the demon to just fifteen minutes.

However, he wasn't that worried, especially since he knows that he can rely on Xiao Hua and Feng Yuxiang.

The scenery suddenly changed from inside the pagoda to this hell-like scenery, where he was surrounded by lava. It looked like he was inside some kind of volcano, but he's never been to such a place before, so he wasn't certain.

One thing that he is certain about is that it was immensely hot in that place with hot air blowing in his face constantly, almost like he was inside an oven.

While Yuan looked around for the demon, he suddenly noticed a figure emerging from the lava.

This demon had an appearance that Yuan hadn't seen before. Instead of its usual red skin, it had grayish skin this time, and it had a broken horn in its forehead that looked as though it'd been cleanly sliced by a sword.

As for its crystal... Of course, it didn't have one.

"When you're prepared to start the challenge, say 'Ready' out loud." The Divine Paragon's voice resounded when the demon stepped onto the platform.

However, before Yuan could even speak, the demon opened its mouth and spoke in a calm but indifferent voice, "You're not worthy."

Yuan frowned, but not because of the demon's arrogance. There was something about this demon that sent shivers down his back, and his instincts were telling him to avoid it at all cost.

But he couldn't just give up without fighting it. He had to at least try.

'I will be fine with Xiao Hua and Feng Feng by my side.' Yuan calmed himself down with such words.

The next moment, he summoned both of them before him.

"Young Master, I am getting a dangerous feeling from that demon." Feng Yuxiang said to him the moment she appeared.

Xiao Hua agreed with Feng Yuxiang by nodding her head.

"We got this." Yuan said.

Once they were prepared, Yuan spoke out loud, "Ready!"

The instant he uttered that word, the demon disappeared from its location before any of them could even make their move.

"YOUNG MASTER!"

"BROTHER YUAN! WATCH OUT!"

Both Feng Yuxiang and Xiao Hua suddenly shouted out loud at the same time, their voices filled with despair.

However, Yuan couldn't understand why they screamed— at least not until he felt pain in his body.

Yuan looked down at his body, and to his absolute surprise, there was an arm sticking out of his body.

He turned around to see the demon standing behind him with its arm extended through his body.

'How the...'

"I told you. You're not worthy."

The demon mumbled in a low voice before releasing a massive amount of spiritual energy into Yuan's body, causing his body to explode into countless pieces.

When Xiao Hua and Feng Yuxiang witnessed this scene— the scene of Yuan's death, their eyes widened with shock.

"How dare you kill Brother Yuan!"

Xiao Hua suddenly roared, and an outburst of spiritual energy that surpassed the demon's aura erupted from her petite body. Her figure also grew a little taller— at least that was what Feng Yuxiang thought she saw before everything went black for both Xiao Hua and Feng Yuxiang.

Their vision returned almost instantly, and when it did, they realized that they were no longer inside the pagoda but outside, and Yuan was standing before them with a dazed expression on his face, almost as though his death never happened.

"B-Brother Yuan!" Xiao Hua immediately went to embrace him.

"Xiao Hua? What happened? I thought I died just now..." Yuan snapped out of his daze when he felt Xiao Hua arms wrapped around his waist.

"That's because you didn't actually die." Yan Hara's voice suddenly resounded.

Yuan turned to look at her, and to his surprise, a crowd of people that wasn't there before he entered the pagoda was there now.

"When you die inside the Demon Sealing Pagoda, you will simply be transported out of the pagoda." She continued.

After hearing her words, Yuan recalled one of the rules that mentioned it.

"I see... So I lost— died to that demon..." Yuan mumbled in a dispirited voice.

"What floor did you die on?" Yan Hara then asked.

"I died on the fourth floor by the hands of that weird-looking demon with gray skin." Yuan explained to her.

"It was so sudden. I couldn't even see its movements, and when I was aware of the situation, I was already dead."

"T-The fourth floor?" Yan Hara mumbled in a voice of disbelief.

Yuan had only been in the Demon Sealing Pagoda for an hour, and he'd managed to reach the fourth floor? Even more unbelievable was that he'd actually reached the fourth floor on his first attempt, something that hasn't been done since ancient times.

In fact, it took Yan Hara multiple attempts throughout the span of 1,000 years to reach the fourth floor!

"Just what in heaven's name was that gray demon? I have never encountered a demon like that one before." Yuan suddenly asked.

Yan Hara sighed, "That demon is a Demon Emperor— sort of."

"What do you mean 'sort of'?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"I will tell you later. For now, let's leave this place and go somewhere more private. As you can see, it's a little crowded here."

Yuan nodded.

"By the way, who are those two? They appeared at the same time you left the pagoda, but I didn't see them enter with you." Yan Hara pointed at Feng Yuxiang and Xiao Hua, who was still hugging Yuan.

"They are my companions... I will explain later.." Yuan said with a smile.

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Chapter 804 - Demon On The Fourth Floor

"W-Wait!" Someone there stopped Yuan from leaving with Yan Hara.

Yuan turned around to see a middle-aged man that he did not recognize, and he asked, "What is it?"

"Did anything unusual happen in the Demon Sealing Pagoda while you were inside?" The middle-aged man asked.

"Unusual?" Yuan raised his eyebrows. "How unusual? That was my first time entering the Demon Sealing Pagoda, so I can't tell you if anything is out of the ordinary even if it happened."

"If you don't mind, can you give us a brief explanation on your experience inside the pagoda?" The middle-aged man continued to ask.

"Can I ask why you want to know?"

The middle-aged man then said, "Because the Divine Paragon showed up when you entered the Demon Sealing Pagoda! That has never happened before!"

"What? The Divine Paragon showed up?" Yuan was shocked to hear this.

He should be the Divine Paragon, so how did someone who is supposed to be dead and reincarnated show up?

"W-Well... Not the real Divine Paragon, but an illusion of him... He showed up after you entered the pagoda, even releasing this unfathomable

demon sealing aura. However, he disappeared after a few minutes, and only a handful of people were able to witness it."

"I see... So that's what happened. Unfortunately, I didn't see the Divine Paragon inside, but I did hear his voice. This is what happened inside—"

Yuan proceeded to give a brief recollection of his experience within the pagoda to the people there.

After hearing Yuan's story, the people there no longer questioned him, as they did not find anything unusual with his experience inside the Demon Sealing Pagoda.

"Can I go now?" Yuan asked.

"Y-Yes. Sorry for bothering you, little founder." The middle-aged man bowed to him in a respectful manner.

Although slowly, the people within the Demon Sealing Clan's Grand Library were beginning to treat Yuan differently.

Perhaps it was due to his uncanny resemblance to the Divine Paragon, or maybe they were just convinced by his overwhelming talents, these people were beginning to see Yuan as a potential leader of the Demon Sealing Clan in the future.

Sometime later, Yuan followed Yan Hara to her personal living quarters. All official lecturers are granted residency within the Grand Library.

"Are you okay? You seem off." Yan Hara asked him once they sat down.

Yuan showed a bittersweet smile before speaking, "I experienced my first death today. Even though it wasn't real, it felt real, and the fact that I had been killed by a demon is also real. I... I have overestimated myself today and put my companions' lives at risk."

"Fortunately, the demon wasn't real. If we had been facing a real demon outside the pagoda, I would've not only gotten myself killed but my companions as well, and the thought of this really bothers me..."

"Brother Yuan..." Xiao Hua, who was still sticking to his body like a slug, mumbled in a low voice.

Clearly, she was also affected by Yuan's death. Not only did she fail to protect him, but he also died right before her eyes.

"Xiao Hua promised to protect Brother Yuan, but..." She sighed with teary eyes.

This is the first time that Yuan has seen Xiao Hua cry with such emotions, and it made his heart sting.

"If we're all going to blame ourselves, then I blame myself for not being able to protect you, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang sighed as well.

Seeing their depressed state and sensing the gloomy atmosphere, Yan Hara spoke out loud, "There's no need to blame yourself— all of you. You were up against a Demon Emperor, after all. Let me tell you something. Ever since the disappearance of the Divine Paragon and the decline of the Demon Sealing Clan, nobody has been able to pass the fourth floor of the Demon Sealing Pagoda, and only a handful of demon sealers were able to pass the third floor."

Yuan looked at her and asked, "You said that it was 'sort of' a Demon Emperor before."

"Ah, that's because the gray-skin demon isn't truly a Demon Emperor, but it's so much more powerful than a Demon General that we cannot call it a mere Demon General. However, a real Demon Emperor is even more fearsome than the demon on the fourth floor."

"It's something like a Cultivator who is half a step away from entering the next realm. It's at a level that far surpasses anything at the same rank, yet it's not truly at the next rank." Yan Hara explained.

"I see... That makes a lot of sense. But for it to be that powerful when it's not even a true Demon Emperor... It makes me wonder about the real strength of a true Demon Emperor." Yuan sighed.

"Trust me, you don't want to find out." Yan Hara smiled.

Sometime later, Yan Hara focused her gaze on Xiao Hua and Feng Yuxiang, "By the way... Can you explain who they are... and why the little one is emitting the aura of an Exile?"

Yuan's body shook when he heard Yan Hara's words. It was also at this moment that he recalled Senior Bai's words— that those from the upper heavens would recognize Xiao Hua to be an exile and that Exiles are hunted in the upper heavens.

"W-Wait! I can explain! Xiao Hua isn't a bad exile!" Yuan immediately became defensive.

Yan Hara smiled when she saw this, and she said, "Calm down. Although I am not someone who favors exiles, I am also not someone who would hunt them on sight. Honestly, I couldn't care less."

"W-While that may be true, what about all those people at the Demon Sealing Pagoda? If you can tell that she's an exile, they should also know!" Yuan said.

"Trust me, if they noticed, you wouldn't have been able to leave in one piece. Her exile aura is really weak right now for some reason, and I didn't notice it until we sat down," she explained.

Yuan finally calmed down a little after hearing such words.

"Thankfully, Senior Yan isn't an unreasonable person..." He sighed inwardly.

Chapter 805 - Not Human

"She is Xiao Hua, and this one over here is Feng Yuxiang." Yuan pointed at them and introduced them to Yan Hara.

"Although they're my servants, I prefer to call them my companions."

Yan Hara raised her eyebrows and asked, "Normal servants wouldn't be able to enter the Demon Sealing Pagoda with you, so they must have signed a contract that binds their soul with your soul. In other words, they are no different than the Soul Weapons that you carry around with you in your body."

"That is correct. We are more than just 'servants'. We are his most loyal servants— his weapon and shield." Feng Yuxiang said in a prideful voice.

"I see... And since she's an exile, you must be participating in the Supreme Heaven's Legacy. How troublesome..." Yan Hara sighed.

And she continued, "You do know what it means to accept the Supreme Heaven's Legacy or the consequences of siding with an exile, right?"

"I do." Yuan immediately nodded with a serious face.

"If others from the Demon Sealing Clan or the Demon Sealing Grotto learn that you're helping an exile, it will become immensely more difficult for you to become the next leader, and there's a good chance that you could even get kicked out of the clan..." Yan Hara sighed.

"If you're asking me to choose between the Demon Sealing Clan or Xiao Hua, I would choose the latter without any hesitation." Yuan quickly said with a resolute face.

"Let's not get ahead of yourself..." A bittersweet smile appeared on Yan Hara's face.

"You might not care about the Demon Sealing Clan, but as your lecturer, I truly want you to become the next leader of the Demon Sealing Clan, and after what happened at the Demon Sealing Pagoda today, I believe that the Divine Paragon also saw something special within you, hence why he appeared when you entered the pagoda."

"Once the higher ups learn of what happened today, they will definitely start paying more attention to you, and they might even outright approach you, so I suggest you keep your little friend hidden for as long as you're inside the Grand Library."

"I will keep that in mind." Yuan nodded.

"You should also keep in mind that even if she is hidden in your body, there are people out there that can still see her. If you truly want to keep her safe, you'll need a treasure that blocks all probing, but in order to acquire a treasure powerful enough to block even the most powerful cultivators... it won't be easy."

"I would help you, but I do not have the capabilities to acquire such a powerful treasure."

"It's okay, I will figure something out. Thank you, Senior, for your help." Yuan said to her.

"I am your lecturer—I am supposed to help you, even if the subject is a little... unethical..." Yan Hara smiled.

And she continued while looking directly at Xiao Hua, "By the way, you should probably go back. Your exile aura... It's getting stronger."

However, Xiao Hua immediately refused by shaking her head, and her grasp on Yuan tightened.

Seeing this, Yuan patted her head and said, "It's okay, Xiao Hua. I am safe in this place. What happened in the Demon Sealing Pagoda was due to my carelessness. It won't happen again."

"Damn right you are safe in this place! Who would dare to touch you, who has the face of the Divine Paragon, in this place filled with his admirers and fanatics? That would be a crime punishable by death!" Yan Hara added.

After a moment of silence, Xiao Hua nodded her head and reluctantly returned inside Yuan's body.

As for Feng Yuxiang, she decided to stay outside for a little longer since she wasn't worried about getting hunted.

Yan Hara's attention turned to look at Feng Yuxiang now that Xiao Hua's presence was gone, and she asked, "You have a unique aura around you. It's like you're human but also not at the same time. What are you?"

In response to Yan Hara's question, Feng Yuxiang changed her hair to red and her eyes to golden.

Yan Hara's eyes widened with shock when she realized what she was looking at.

"Y-You're a phoenix?" Yan Hara muttered in a voice of disbelief.

"Is there a problem with that?" Feng Yuxiang said.

Yan Hara swallowed nervously and said, "Phoenixes are some of the most prideful creatures roaming in the Nine Heavens alongside dragons. I cannot imagine a creature like that would be willing to become a human's servant — binded through your souls, much less."

Feng Yuxiang coldly snorted and said, "I am not just the servant of any 'human'. The Young Master is special. I wouldn't even categorize him as human. He's different from the rest of you humans."

Yuan raised his eyebrows and said, "You don't see me as human?"

"I-I don't mean it like that... You're human... but above a human at the same time— like a celestial being." Feng Yuxiang tried to explain herself.

Yan Hara couldn't help but let out a chuckle after hearing Feng Yuxiang's words, and she said, "You know, according to some ancient document, after the Divine Paragon conquered the Demonic Realm, there were countless Divine Beasts that would offer themselves to serve him. And yes, this included phoenixes and even dragons. You're truly resembling the Divine Paragon more and more now, Yuan."

"The Divine Paragon was truly someone special. He was a human like the rest of us, but there was something about him that made him stand out from the rest of us— at least this is what some people during his era said."

Sometime later, Yan Hara asked Yuan, "Do you have any questions for me?"

He nodded and spoke, "I want to challenge the demon on the fourth floor again, and I want to defeat it. Can you help me?"

Yan Hara then said, "If you want to challenge the pagoda again, you'll have to wait 30 days, and we'll have to pay for the resources by ourselves this time."

"I am fine with that." Yuan said.

"Then let me ask you another question— what do you think you need to defeat the demon?" She asked him.

Chapter 806 - Demon Sealing Groups

"Well... I'm one level away from reaching Spirit King. If I reach Spirit King, perhaps I can..."

However, Yan Hara immediately scoffed at his response, "Increasing your cultivation will only help you slightly. In fact, it's the last thing you should worry about in the Demon Sealing Pagoda."

"Did you already forget? The Demon Sealing Pagoda scales to your cultivation strength, so if you grow stronger, so do the demons."

After being reminded of this fact, Yuan frowned and asked, "Then what am I supposed to do?"

Yan Hara smiled and said, "Everything else."

"The Demon Sealing Pagoda takes into account your cultivation and your talents to a certain extent. However, your experience and techniques do not affect the pagoda. If you want to defeat the demon on the fourth floor and beyond, you'll need to increase your experience and improve on your techniques. Oh, your demon sealing aura will play a huge role as well."

"Experience... So I just need to fight more demons?"

"Not just fight demons. You need to fight demons much stronger than yourself. I'm sure you can kill a thousand Lower Demons at your level with ease, but that won't help you defeat a Demon Emperor. If you want to improve, you need to push yourself to your limits."

"Pushing the Young Master to his limits... It won't be easy." Feng Yuxiang said.

Yan Hara smiled and said, "I know, that's why I will personally train you. I may not be the strongest cultivator out there, but I am more than enough to show you true despair. Meet me at the Grand Library next week after the tournament."

"Tournament?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"Oh, right. I was going to tell you about it, but the situation with the Demon Sealing Pagoda had distracted me."

Yan Hara then continued, "In three days, there will be a tournament for Master Demon Sealers such as myself, and I want you to be there to witness it. You might learn a thing or two about fighting demons."

Yuan nodded, "I will be there. Where is it?"

"It will be located at the Demon Sealing Clan's Grand Coliseum. You won't be able to get there by yourself, so you'll need to be invited."

Yan Hara retrieved a red medallion and handed it to him afterward.

"This will take you to the location. Activate it with your spiritual energy. However, I should warn you that it would be for the best if you don't bring the exile with you, as there will be many powerful cultivators in that place."

"I understand..."

"Anyways, do you have any more questions for me?"

Yuan pondered for a moment before asking, "You told me to strengthen my demon sealing aura, but how does that work? Do I just need to learn as many demon sealing techniques as possible?"

Yan Hara nodded, and she spoke, "Not just learn them— you need to understand and fully master them."

"But how can I comprehend a technique that I cannot use? For example, I use the sword mostly, but there are demon sealing techniques for the bow and many other weapons that I have never used before."

"You don't need to use a technique to master it. The most important thing when it comes to mastering a technique is comprehension. Of course, it would be much easier to comprehend something you understand, but it's not impossible to comprehend something you don't understand at first. It'll just take you much longer."

"As for using the technique... It would also help you to master a technique much quicker if you practice with it everyday than someone who only reads the technique."

Yuan then asked, "The fastest method to master a technique is to use it constantly, right?"

"Yes." Yan Hara nodded.

And she continued, "In the Grand Library, there is an area that will let you practice your techniques as many times as you want, and there is even a formation in that place that increases your spiritual energy regeneration, allowing you to recover faster and practice more. However, that place is only accessible by Elite Demon Sealers and above."

"Elite Demon Sealer... How far away is it from an Advanced Demon Sealer?"

"It's literally your next rank." Yan Hara chuckled.

"Oh... Then can I take the examination right away?"

"Well... You'll need at least three Master Demon Sealers to witness the examination, but most of them are busy preparing for the tournament, so you'll have to wait until the tournament is over."

"If you want to start practicing now, there is an open area that is accessible by all demon sealers. You can practice there, but you are limited to what

techniques you can use— mostly the destructive ones."

"What about the Demon Sealing Strike?"

"That is fine."

"Okay, then I want to start my training as soon as possible."

"Alright, follow me."

Before Yuan followed Yan Hara outside, Feng Yuxiang turned into a ball of flame and entered Yuan's body.

Sometime later, they arrived at this spacious area where it was simply an open area where people could be seen practicing their techniques out in the open.

"Although this place is meant for demon sealers to practice their demon sealing techniques, it is also a place where demon sealers show off their talents and hope to be recruited into a group."

"What kind of group?" Yuan asked.

"There are many small groups within the Demon Sealing Clan and the Demon Sealing Grotto. Most of these groups consist of four to five demon sealers, and they operate as a team to hunt demons. This is great for newcomers and even veteran demon sealers, as popular groups receive more attention and support by the upper echelons."

"And just for the record, I do not belong to any group, mostly because I like to operate alone." Yan Hara said.

"I see..."

"Anyways, you can practice here for as long as you like. Just make sure you don't forget about the tournament. If you don't show up and I lose, I will blame it on you." Yan Hara said to him a moment later.

"Don't worry, I will definitely be there." Yuan said.

Yan Hara left the scene shortly after while Yuan found an empty spot in the area and began practicing the Demon Sealing Strike by using it repeatedly, almost as though he'd become a robot with a single purpose.

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Chapter 807 - Wrong Decision

[Demon Sealing Strike!]

Yuan swung the Empyrean Overlord with all of his might in the empty air before him, sweeping the area in front with an invisible ripple of demon sealing aura.

After that, he pulled the sword back and went for another strike, and he would continue this for two whole hours until someone approached him.

"You're not doing it right."

Yuan stopped swinging the sword and turned to look at the handsome man standing beside him.

"Senior Wan..."

It was Wan Yu, the lecturer that guided him around the Grand Library on his first day.

"Something came up, so I had to leave this place for a bit. Looks like a lot has happened since then." Wan Yu said with a smile on his face.

"I cannot believe that I didn't notice it when I first met you, but you truly look like the founder. I also heard that you'd decided to join the Demon Sealing Clan. Can I ask why you chose them instead of the Demon Sealing Grotto?"

"Sorry, but there is just something about the Demon Sealing Clan that makes me feel... at home... And it feels like it was only natural for me to join them."

"I see... You don't have to apologize. You're not wrong for choosing one over the other... I mean, it might have been the wrong decision, but you did nothing wrong. I understand why you feel the need to join the Demon Sealing Clan. I was once in your shoes, but as I spent more time with them, I realized that the Demon Sealing Clan is no longer the brilliance it once was."

"Without the Divine Paragon, the Demon Sealing Clan is just another power — one of countless powers out there. You will realize that soon, and when you do, you know where to find me. I won't give up on you just because you joined them."

Wan Yu then pointed at the Empyrean Overlord and said, "If your technique doesn't improve after every swing, you're doing something wrong. Don't just swing the sword. You need to understand and comprehend the technique, or your technique will remain the same even a thousand swings later."

"T-Thank you for the advice, Senior." Yuan said to him.

"We may belong to different powers, but I am still an official lecturer here. Regardless if you are from the Demon Sealing Clan or the Demon Sealing Grotto, I have a responsibility to guide you properly."

"Anyways, good luck. Ah, good work at the Demon Sealing Pagoda. I heard you managed to reach the fourth floor on your first attempt." Wan Yu said to Yuan before leaving the place.

After Yuan was alone again, Feng Yuxiang's voice resounded, "That man is right, Young Master. You shouldn't swing your sword just for the sake of swinging it. You must try to understand the technique and improve it as you swing it."

"Close your eyes and swing the sword. Try to feel it. Once you can feel it, you can start understanding it."

Yuan nodded and closed his eyes.

After taking a deep but calm breath, he released the Demon Sealing Strike.

'I see... It really feels different than swinging it casually.' Yuan thought to himself.

"Now try to see if you can improve the technique before you swing it again." Feng Yuxiang said.

Yuan nodded.

A few minutes later, Yuan moved again, swinging the Empyrean Overlord.

Although it was only slightly, Feng Yuxiang noticed slight improvement in his movements.

"That's perfect, Young Master. You're improving."

"Thank you, Feng Feng. I think I know what to do now."

Yuan said to her, and he continued to practice the Demon Sealing Strike.

While Yuan practiced his technique, Feng Yuxiang spoke to Xiao Hua using spiritual sense.

"Hey, Xiao Hua, I have been dying to ask you... When we were inside the Demon Sealing Pagoda, I thought I saw you growing taller... What was that about?"

"What are you talking about, Phoenix?" Xiao Hua responded in a puzzled voice.

"You know... When the Young Master died before us... You got angry, and I swear I noticed you growing taller..."

"You must have been seeing things. Xiao Hua has no idea what you're talking about." Xiao Hua responded in a genuinely puzzled voice.

"Probably..." Feng Yuxiang also began to believe that she was just seeing things because of her shock at the time.

A few hours later, Yuan manages to increase the Demon Sealing Strike's Master Level to 2.

<Your comprehension for Demon Sealing Strike has improved significantly through training>

<Your comprehension for Demon Sealing Strike has reached a new level>

<Demon Sealing Strike Master Level (1) → (2)>

[Demon Sealing Strike]

[Rank: Heaven]

[Mastery Level: 2]

However, Yuan didn't stop his training even after his Demon Sealing Strike reached a new level. In fact, he continued training even harder.

He would swing the Empyrean Overlord for the entire day until his arms were sore and his body was soaked in sweat.

When the other demon sealers at the scene saw how hard he was training, their motivation also grew, allowing them to train harder.

At the end of the day, Yuan's Demon Sealing Strike reached Master Level 3, and his demon sealing aura also saw significant growth.

"I will see you guys tomorrow." Yuan said goodbye to his companions before logging off the game.

After logging off, Yuan got off the bed and made his way to the training field behind the mansion to continue his training.

Of course, there were already people training in the field way before his arrival.

"Hey, Yuan. How was your day?" Wang Ming asked him.

"It was a difficult day for me. One filled with disappointment." Yuan responded with a bittersweet smile.

"You want to talk about it?" Wang Ming did not expect such a response from him and asked.

Yuan chuckled, "Don't worry, I already have it all sorted out with my lecturer."

"Lecturer?"

"I will introduce you guys to her in the future. She's an experienced demon sealer in Cultivation Online."

"By the way, how's your progress with the demon sealing technique?" Yuan asked.

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Chapter 808 - Killing Two Birds With One Stone

"My progress with the Demon Sealing Strike has been great. I should be able to use it by the end of this week." Wang Ming said.

He then pointed in a certain direction and said, "Li Jinxi, on the other hand, has been using the technique since yesterday. It won't be long before she masters it."

Yuan used his divine sense to watch Li Jinxi, and sure enough, her sword would release demon sealing aura with every swing. However, the demon sealing aura is still very weak— too weak to actually seal any demons.

"Good luck with your training." Yuan said to Wang Ming before walking over to Li Jinxi.

"Can I help you a bit?" Yuan asked her.

Li Jinxi stopped swinging the sword and nodded.

Yuan walked beside her and gently grabbed her arms before adjusting their position.

Once her arms were in the correct position, Yuan moved to adjust her hips, then her legs, and lastly, her feet.

"Try swinging your sword now," he said to her.

Li Jinxi nodded and swung the large sword in her hand.

Whoosh!

A strong gust of wind appeared from the swing, and it felt much easier and comfortable for Li Jinxi.

"Thank you." She said to him afterward.

"When you practice the technique, you should try to feel and understand it. Someone told me that your technique should improve with every strike—even if it's slightly." Yuan said.

"I will keep that in mind."

Yuan walked to the others and also gave them advice.

Eventually, he reached Meixiu, who was practicing with her bow.

Whoosh!

Using her black bow that she acquired from the Six Spiritual Families, Meixiu was able to hit her target a thousand meters away, and the arrow even managed to hit the tiny red dot in the center.

Meixiu gracefully lowered her arms after releasing the arrow, and she turned to look at him, "Hey."

"Hey, that was quite impressive." Yuan said with a smile.

"I don't think I have any advice for you, nor am I qualified to lecture you."

"What do you think of my form?" Meixiu then asked.

"I think it was beautiful."

"What about the demon sealing aura? Is it strong enough to seal a demon?"

"Unfortunately, you would need to shoot the demon a hundred times if you want to seal it." Yuan said.

"I see..." Meixiu looked slightly disappointed by the results.

"Don't look so down. You're doing great for someone who just started learning demon sealing techniques." Yuan gave her some encouragement.

"Thank you." Meixiu said to him before returning to her training.

Yuan decided to let her train in peace and check on Chu Liuxiang next.

"Ha!"

As he got close to her, Chu Liuxiang shot her palm forward, sending a wave of demon sealing aura into the air.

"What do you think of my Demon Sealing Pulse?" Chu Liuxiang turned to look at him afterward.

"Your demon sealing aura is the strongest out of everyone at the moment. This means you have the deepest comprehension of your demon sealing technique. Good job."

"Thanks, but I still feel a little lacking with one demon sealing technique." She sighed.

"Don't worry, I will acquire more demon sealing techniques in a few days."

"Okay."

Sometime later, Yuan walked to an empty spot on the field and started his own training.

Everyone would train without rest until it was time for dinner.

Meixiu left an hour earlier than everyone else to prepare for dinner.

During dinner, they would talk about their progress with their techniques and things they did in Cultivation Online.

"What about you, Yuan?" Shi Lang suddenly asked him.

Yuan swallowed before responding with a bittersweet smile, "I died today."

Clang

Everybody there dropped their utensils when they heard his words, and they turned to look at him with wide eyes.

"E-Excuse me? Can you repeat that? I think I misheard you just now." Wang Ming stuttered in a voice of disbelief.

"I experienced death today. Don't worry, it wasn't real death, so it didn't affect me in the slightest— at least not physically." Yuan explained to them in more detail about his situation.

"I fought a very powerful demon in the Demon Sealing Pagoda, where demon sealers go to train in the Grand Library. If you die inside the pagoda, you won't actually die, and you will simply be teleported outside. I managed to reach the peak of Spirit Lord after passing three out of nine floors."

"Good lord, you're already almost a Spirit King? That's ridiculous..."

The others were simply speechless. While everyone else was still trying to climb Spirit Warrior, Yuan was already one level away from Spirit King. Will they ever close their distance?

"I-I'm going to train some more tonight after dinner..." Wang Bingbing muttered in a low voice.

"M-Me too." Shi Lang agreed.

Half of the room decided to continue their training after dinner within moments.

Sometime after dinner, Yuan returned to his room with Chu Liuxiang.

"Yuan— Darling, now that we've returned home, let's... you know... 'do it'." Chu Liuxiang said as she stared at him with an eager look on her pretty face.

"N-Now? You still have energy after training for an entire day?" Yuan said in a dumbfounded voice.

"No matter how exhausted I am, I will always have energy to embrace my love!" She chuckled.

Yuan showed a slight smile before nodding, "But let me clean myself first. My body is still sticky from training."

"Oka— Wait! We can do this inside the bathroom! We can clean ourselves and embrace each other at the same time! That would be killing two birds with one stone!" Chu Liuxiang suddenly suggested.

Yuan was truly speechless this time.

However, he didn't refuse and nodded in silence.

"Great!"

They removed their clothes and entered the bathroom together shortly after, spending much more time than usual inside.

"That was amazing, darling..." Chu Liuxiang said to him on the bed about three hours later.

"Good night, Lulu." Yuan said to her with a smile before he walked to the balcony.

"You're not going to sleep tonight?"

Yuan summoned the Empyrean Overlord before responding, "I'm going to practice a little more tonight. You don't need to wait for me. Get some rest."

He jumped onto the sword and flew away from their balcony.

Chapter 809 - Max Mastery Level

"Good night, darling..." Chu Liuxiang mumbled in a low voice after Yuan flew away.

She laid on the bed a moment later and quickly fell asleep with a peaceful and satisfied smile on her face.

Meanwhile, Yuan flew circles around the Dragon Spiral Mountain on his flying sword in order to practice his Qi Manifestation.

Of course, he would need to rest after every lap around the Dragon Spiral Mountain.

After his ninth lap around the Dragon Spiral Mountain, Yuan noticed Meixiu's figure from above, and she appeared to be training her movement technique.

Yuan decided to stay in the air and watch Meixiu dance around with elegance yet precision.

A few minutes later, he descended in front of her and said, "Don't overwork yourself again, Meixiu."

She smiled and said, "Don't worry, I won't embarrass myself like that again."

"You know, I have never collapsed like that before— not even when I was worked to the bone by my mother."

"..."

After a moment of silence, Yuan said, "Let's take a break."

"Huh?"

Meixiu raised her eyebrows.

Yuan suddenly lowered his body, picked Meixiu up and carried her like a princess.

He then hopped onto the Empyrean Overlord and flew into the air with Meixiu still in his arms.

Meixiu subconsciously hugged Yuan's neck when they flew into the air, which reminded her of their first time flying together.

"What do you think?" Yuan asked her as they hovered above the Dragon Spiral Mountain.

"It's... beautiful." She mumbled in a dazed voice.

"Meixiu... Even if you're behind everyone, it's okay. In fact, you could be the weakest person in this world, I would still want you to be by my side, and that will never change no matter what happens."

Meixiu was in a daze after hearing Yuan's words, and after a moment of silence, she showed a bashful smile on her beautiful face.

"Yuan... You're becoming more cheeky. I fear what might happen in the future..."

"C-Cheeky?" Yuan was speechless.

"But I—"

"Kiss me." Meixiu suddenly interrupted.

Yuan halted whatever he wanted to say and immediately kissed her on the lips.

After their kiss, Meixiu mumbled in a low voice, "Yuan... Tonight... Can you stay with me?"

"Okay." Yuan nodded without hesitation.

He quickly finished his final lap around the Dragon Spiral Mountain before flying Meixiu back to her room.

They entered her room through the balcony, and once inside, Meixiu started kissing him again.

After a few minutes of passionate kissing, Meixiu removed her clothes and dragged Yuan to the bed, where they started to embrace each other shortly after.

Sometime later, Meixiu fell asleep in her bed without even bothering to clean up or wear her clothes.

Yuan wanted to continue his training after embracing Meixiu, but he was simply too tired after being squeezed dry by two beautiful women in the same night, so he just fell asleep in the same bed as Meixiu.

The following morning, Meixiu woke up with her body feeling a little sore.

She turned to look at Yuan, who was still sleeping peacefully beside her.

After staring at his face for a few moments, she left the bed without waking him up and went to take a shower.

Once she was fully dressed, she woke Yuan up.

"It's morning."

Once Yuan was awake and dressed, Meixiu said, "I will go prepare breakfast."

"Okay."

Yuan returned to his room, where Chu Liuxiang was still sound asleep.

"Lulu, it's morning." Yuan decided to wake her up.

"Five... more minutes..." Chu Liuxiang said in a drowsy voice.

Sometime later, once breakfast was finished and served, Yuan logged back into Cultivation Online for another day of training.

At the end of the day, his Demon Sealing Strike rose another two levels, reaching Mastery Level 5, becoming his highest level technique.

Near the end of the third day, Yuan suddenly stopped training and took a seat on the ground and closed his eyes.

The demon sealers around him quickly noticed the odd aura he was giving off, and when they recognized what was happening, they all stopped their training.

"The little founder is experiencing enlightenment..."

When someone is experiencing enlightenment, it was common courtesy for those around that person to stop whatever they were doing so that they wouldn't distract the person having the enlightenment.

Furthermore, it was the famous little founder who was experiencing enlightenment. Nobody there wanted to be responsible for distracting Yuan and invoking Yan Hara's fury.

And for the next few hours, the entire training area was sealed off by the demon sealers so that Yuan could complete his enlightenment in peace.

<Your comprehension for Demon Sealing Strike has improved tremendously through enlightenment>

<Your comprehension for Demon Sealing Strike has reached a new level>

<Demon Sealing Strike Master Level (9) → (Max)>

[Demon Sealing Strike]

[Rank: Heaven]

[Mastery Level: Max]

<Demon Sealing Strike has reached max mastery>

<Demon Sealing Strike's Rank has increased to Divine!>

[Demon Sealing Strike]

[Rank: Divine]

[Mastery Rank: Max]

Right before Yuan came out of his enlightenment and opened his eyes, his body suddenly radiated with immense demon sealing aura that rippled throughout the Demon Sealing Clan's Grand Library.

Yuan opened his eyes a few moments later and stood up, feeling as though something within him had changed.

The demon sealers waiting outside the training area stormed inside when they realized that Yuan had finished his enlightenment.

They surrounded him and began throwing him praises.

"Congratulations, Little Founder, on your successful enlightenment!"

"T-Thank you..."

Feeling overwhelmed by the people there, Yuan decided to run away, disappearing somewhere in the Grand Library.

Of course, even if Yuan ran away, it did not stop the people there from spreading news of his enlightenment.

Eventually, news of Yuan's enlightenment reached Yan Hara's ears.

"The Little Founder experienced enlightenment and finished it?" A wide smile appeared on her face after hearing the news, and she couldn't stop smiling even many minutes later.

"My student is so amazing.. As his lecturer, I cannot disgrace myself in tomorrow's tournament. I must prove to the others that I am worthy to be his lecturer!"

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Chapter 810 - Min Lis Plans

Chapter 810 - Min Li's Plans

The following morning, Yuan woke up earlier than usual and left a note for Chu Liuxiang, telling her that he would not be able to eat breakfast with them today because he had important business within Cultivation Online.

After putting the note on the table beside the bed, Yuan placed the helmet on his head and appeared inside Cultivation Online.

When he logged on, he could see Min Li sitting at the table by the window inside their hotel.

"Good morning," she turned to look at him and said.

"Good morning."

And she continued, "Yuan, I have finally decided on what I want to do."

"Oh? What are your plans?"

"The Seven Spirit Academies will be starting their disciple examination earlier this year because of the sudden influence of people coming from the Lower Heavens, and I plan on taking it."

"That sounds like a great idea. Do you know which sect you want to join yet?"

"My number one option would definitely be the Heavenly Academy. They have been ranked one for the past ten thousand years, and they have produced over 10 Spirit Kings throughout those years."

"However, I would be satisfied with joining any of the Seven Spiritual Academies since they're the best of the best in the Spirit Heaven, and it's incredibly hard to get accepted into any of these places. Even the Universal

Music Academy that focuses on Music Cultivation is better than many top cultivation sects out there."

"Do you know when the examinations will take place? I would like to be there for you till the end. It might be a very long time until we see each other again, after all."

"Yes, it will begin in two weeks."

"I see... I will definitely be there. What do you plan on doing until then?"

"I am going to train near the examination area until then."

Yuan pondered for a moment before speaking, "I will leave one of my companions with you just in case anything goes south during your training. Are you okay with that?"

"R-Really? You don't have to do that for me..." Min Li said.

"Yes, I am sure. Xiao Hua, can you stay with Min Li for the time being since it will be dangerous to take you with me to the tournament?" Yuan said to her.

Xiao Hua appeared beside him the next second with a reluctant look on her face.

"Xiao Hua doesn't want to leave Brother Yuan alone..." She said in a worried voice.

"He won't be alone. Did you forget about Lan Yingying and myself already?" Feng Yuxiang appeared and said.

"We'll take care of the Young Master while you're away."

"But..." Xiao Hua was still reluctant to leave Yuan's side.

"Listen here, Xiao Hua. If you stay with the Young Master, you'll put him at risk just with your presence alone. Do you want to cause trouble for the Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang asked with a frown on her face.

"No..." Xiao Hua lowered her head in a dejected manner.

"Then you should stop being so selfish and go with Min Li for now. We'll see you again as soon as possible."

"..."

Seeing Xiao Hua's dejected mood, Yuan lowered his body and embraced her small body.

"I will be fine, Xiao Hua. Not only will Feng Feng and Yingying be there with me, Senior Yan and many powerful demon sealers will be there with me as well."

"I also want to take you with me, but as Senior Yan mentioned, there will be many powerful figures there that could expose you, and I don't want you to be in danger. In fact, I would even put your safety above my own, so can you stay with Min Li for the time being? When I return... We can play catch again like we used to."

Xiao Hua immediately lifted her head and stared at him with her big round eyes that were filled with emotion— mostly excitement.

"Really?"

Yuan nodded, "I promise."

"Okay, Xiao Hua will go with her."

"Great! Then we'll see you two later."

After saying their goodbyes, Yuan left the hotel with Feng Yuxiang and Lan Yingying. They flew until they were a few miles away from the city.

"Senior Yan said I only need my spiritual energy to activate it..." Yuan retrieved the red medallion Yan Hara had given him and started pouring his spiritual energy into it.

Immediately, the red medallion began emitting a bright crimson light.

A few seconds later, the red medallion shattered into countless pieces, dumbfounding Yuan.

"D-Did I break it?" He swallowed nervously.

"No, it's activating right now, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang said to him.

The very next moment, a beautiful red portal would appear before Yuan.

Once the portal was fully activated, Feng Yuxiang said, "You can go inside now, Young Master. I don't sense anything malicious from it, so it should be okay."

"Okay."

Yuan nodded, but before he entered the portal, he retrieved a mask and wore it.

Since he looked exactly like the Divine Paragon, there would be no doubt that someone there would recognize him, and he didn't want such a spotlight on him when he's surrounded by so many cultivators that were countless times stronger than him.

After all, he didn't know if the Divine Paragon had any enemies before, nor did he want to find out, so he decided to play it safe.

When he exited the portal, Yuan was greeted by a starry sky and a massive circular building a few miles in the distance.

"Just where are we?" Yuan mumbled in a dazed voice as he looked around with great interest.

"It feels like we're in someone's dimension." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Like Senior Bai's own world?" Yuan asked.

"Yes, just like that."

While Yuan admired the scenery that made him feel like he was in space, other people would appear around him.

These people would glance at Yuan for a brief moment before scoffing and flying away, treating his existence as though it was insignificant.

"Young Master... You should definitely keep your head down here... Even Spirit Sovereigns would look like an ant before these people..." Feng Yuxiang warned him afterward.

"Un.." He nodded silently.

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Chapter 811 - Grand Coliseum

Once he had enough of the scenery, Yuan began making his way towards the large circular building in the distance.

While everyone else flew, Yuan used his legs and walked toward his destination.

"Feng Feng, is there a reason why my spiritual energy isn't stable in this place? This happened when I was teleported to the Fifth Heaven, as well." Yuan decided to ask Feng Yuxiang.

"That's because you're not used to the atmosphere of this place, Young Master. The spiritual energy in this place far surpasses anything you've experienced before, and your body needs time to adjust to it, hence why you cannot use your spiritual energy, not to mention your low cultivation base."

"Low cultivation base? But I am almost a Spirit King." Yuan raised his eyebrows.

How can a Spirit King be considered having a 'low cultivation'?

"Being Spirit King may be an impressive feat in the lower heavens, but in the upper heavens, it is worthless, and you're no different than a Spirit Warrior in the Lower Heaven as a Spirit King in the upper heavens."

"Heavens... Why is the cultivation path so long?"

"It's not just long, Young Master— it's never-ending. Even if you reach the highest known cultivation level, there will always be more levels above that. It is only a matter of who would discover it."

"Is that so... I—"

Just as Yuan was about to ask a question, he was interrupted by a gust of wind.

Yuan looked up to see a beautiful woman floating right above him.

"Looks like you really came." Yan Hara said to him with a smile.

"Of course." Yuan nodded.

"I hope you'll enjoy the show. Ah, I should probably warn you before it starts— you should brace yourself. I wanted you to come here not only to watch the tournament but also to train you."

"Train me?" Yuan asked.

"You'll understand soon. Don't lose consciousness, or you'll miss the whole thing." Yan Hara winked at him before flying towards the building in front of them.

Yuan swallowed nervously after hearing Yan Hara's words, and he wondered what she was talking about as he approached the building.

Once he reached the entrance, he was stopped by a middle-aged man casually sitting by the entrance, who asked him, "Do you have a pass to get in?"

"Huh?" Yuan showed a puzzled face behind his mask.

"You know, the red medallion you used to come to this place." The middle-aged man explained.

Yuan's eyes widened, and he quickly said, "T-That was also a pass?! But mine broke the moment I activated it!"

"That's unfortunate. Looks like you cannot enter without a pass." The middle-aged man shook his head.

Yuan was speechless.

However, before he could say anything else, the middle-aged man suddenly burst out laughing and said, "I am only joking with you, kiddo. Who brought you here? It's really uncommon for cultivators of your level to show up for this event."

"Really? Is there a reason why?" Yuan then asked.

"Why? Obviously, because they cannot handle it."

"It?"

"The demon's killing intent, of course. What else?"

"I see..."

"So? Who brought you here. That person must be a sadist, or confident in your abilities to bring you here."

"Senior Yan." Yuan said.

"Yan? Yan Hara? She actually brought you here?" The middle-aged man expressed surprise after hearing her name.

"That woman is definitely a sadist. You should watch out, kiddo." He said after a moment of silence.

"I-I will..." Yuan nodded in a dazed manner.

"Anyway, you can go take a seat. Since you're only a Spirit King, you should take the seat that's the furthest away from the arena, which would be the seats at the end of the coliseum."

"I understand. Thank you for the advice." Yuan bowed to the middle-aged man before walking into the Grand Coliseum.

"His demon sealing aura is quite ridiculous for someone at his cultivation... Where did Yan Hara pick up this monster? He would've been a valuable presence for the Demon Sealing Clan during the dark day, but alas, he was

born in the wrong era." The middle-aged man mumbled to himself as he watched Yuan's figure disappear into the coliseum.

"Grand Elder Suo, all of the participants have arrived."

Someone appeared before the middle-aged man shortly after Yuan left.

"Alright." The middle-aged man surnamed Suo stood up and disappeared with the other person.

Meanwhile, Yuan followed the other demon sealers to the spectators' area.

Once he arrived, he took a seat all the way towards the end of the coliseum.

'This should be good enough... hopefully. I wouldn't be able to move any further back even if I need to...' Yuan sighed inwardly.

Sometime later, Yuan noticed three figures approaching him from his right.

"Excuse me, do you mind if we sit here?" One of them asked Yuan in a polite voice.

"No, go ahead."

"Thank you."

Yuan then watched as these three individuals sat down, and he couldn't take his eyes off them for some reason.

One of them noticed Yuan staring at them and smiled at him in a friendly manner.

"S-Sorry... That was rude of me." Yuan quickly apologized once he realized that he'd been staring at them.

"Don't worry, we're used to it as triplets."

"Triplets..." Yuan muttered in a low voice.

Two of these three people were beautiful young ladies while the third person was a handsome young man, and while the two ladies looked almost identical to each other with the only difference being their hairstyle, the young man also looked very similar to the ladies.

"Is this your first time to the Grand Coliseum?" The lady sitting beside Yuan suddenly asked him.

"Yes, it is. What about you guys?"

"This is also our first time. We wanted to come last time, but we were only Spirit Kings at that time, so our family did not allow us to come here. Seeing you here as a Spirit King really makes me envious." The lady said.

And she continued, "Oh, I am Lian Er."

"I'm Lian Li." The lady sitting beside her sister, Lian Er, said.

"Lian San," said the young man.

"Hello, I'm Yuan.." Yuan introduced himself last.

Chapter 812 - Leader Of The Demon Sealing Clan

"Yuan, huh? Hey, Yuan, can I ask you a question?" Lian Er suddenly asked.

"Go ahead." He nodded.

"Then... Why are you wearing a mask?"

Yuan smiled behind his mask and said, "I just enjoy wearing masks. It makes me feel safe for some reason."

"I see..."

"Anyways, who are you cheering for this tournament? There will be five Master Demon Sealers participating today."

"I'm cheering for Senior Yan," he responded without hesitation.

"Senior Yan? She's a very powerful demon sealer— best of her generation, so I can see why you would cheer for her. However, I would cheer for Senior Suo, who is the grandson of Grand Elder Suo. Not only was he trained by one of the best demon sealers in the entire Demon Sealing Clan, but rumor has it that he's been trained by the current leader as well."

"Grand Elder Suo? Who is that?" Yuan asked.

"Y-You don't know of the Grand Elders? They're the backbones of the Demon Sealing Clan!" Lian Li exclaimed in a shocked voice after hearing his words.

"Well... I am relatively new to the Demon Sealing Clan, so I am not aware of this stuff yet. I'd appreciate it if you could broaden my views." Yuan explained.

"How'd you get in here if you're new?" The triplets looked at him with raised eyebrows.

"I was invited by Senior Yan."

"Ah... Is that the real reason you're cheering for her?"

Yuan nodded, "Yes, but that's not the only reason. I don't know any of the other participants, so I can only cheer for her."

"Don't worry, you'll learn about the other participants very soon." Lian Er said.

About five minutes later, the rowdy atmosphere suddenly came to a halt even though nothing seemed to have happened.

However, a few moments later, Yuan could see three individuals appearing out of thin air, and they hovered above the coliseum.

When the spectators there saw these figures, they all stood up and bowed to them.

"Greetings, Leader Qian and Grand Elders!"

'Leader?' Yuan raised his eyebrows. He wondered if the current leader of the Demon Sealing Clan was amongst these three individuals.

'That middle-aged man...'

Yuan also recognized the middle-aged man that teased him at the entrance.

The handsome young man standing in the center of the group raised his hand and calmly waved it.

"Sit."

Almost as though his words were backed by a magic force, everyone in the coliseum sat down the next second.

'That's probably the leader of the Demon Sealing Clan...' Yuan thought to himself as he sat down.

Once everyone was seated, these three people took a seat in a special area within the spectators' area.

The handsome young man sat in the middle on a beautiful throne made out of some kind of red jade while the other two sat beside him.

A few moments later, five more figures appeared on the platform in the middle of the coliseum. Yan Hara was amongst them.

"Greetings, Leader Qian and Grand Elders." The five participants bowed to them in a respectful manner.

The handsome man, who looked only to be in his mid-twenties, stood up from his throne and spoke in a calm voice, "Welcome or welcome back to the Demon Sealing Tournament. I, the 8th leader of the Demon Sealing Clan, Qian Chu, shall oversee this year's tournament alongside Grand Elder Suo of the Demon Sealing Clan, and Grand Elder Cen of the Demon Sealing Grotto."

"Our participants this year will be—"

Qian Chu purposefully did not finish his sentence to allow the participants to introduce themselves.

"Suo Rengan of the Demon Sealing Clan." A handsome young man stepped forward and introduced himself in a clear and confident voice.

"Jiang Ziya of the Demon Sealing Grotto." A middle-aged man introduced himself next.

"Yan Hara of the Demon Sealing Clan." Yan Hara stepped forward and gracefully bowed towards Qian Chu's direction.

"Zu Ti of the Demon Sealing Grotto." An old man with a mixture of black and white hair said next.

"Shen Yue of the Demon Sealing Grotto." A beautiful woman with looks that almost rivaled Yan Hara's appearance was the last to introduce herself.

Once all participants introduced themselves, Qian Chu continued to speak, "Today, these five Master Demon Sealers will participate in the Demon Sealing Tournament and compete against each other to become the next Supreme Demon Sealer!"

"Within the Demon Sealing Clan and the Demon Sealing Grotto that has over 500,000 members, there are less than 20 Supreme Demon Sealers combined, so you can imagine the prestige this title carries."

"However, only one of you will be able to become a Supreme Demon Sealer at the end of this tournament. Are you guys ready?" Qian Chu asked the five participants as his sharp gaze stared at them.

"Yes!" They all responded simultaneously.

"Then let's get this event started." Qian Chu said before sitting back on his throne.

The moment Qian Chu sat down, Grand Elder Suo stood up and shouted, "Activate the formations!"

Once the Formation Experts heard Grand Elder Suo's voice, they immediately activated the formation, creating a powerful barrier around the platform, protecting the spectators and preventing the participants from leaving at the same time.

"The formations are activated!" A voice resounded a few moments later.

Upon hearing this, Qian Chu suddenly flicked his sleeves, and a black flag with a red symbol on a golden pole flew out of his sleeves and landed in the middle of the platform.

This flag was wrapped, and there appeared to be something restrained by the flag.

When Yuan saw this flag, he felt a chill run down his spine, and his blood began boiling, almost as though it was reacting to the flag.

The flag slowly unwrapped itself after landing, revealing to the spectators what it had been restricting— a demon.

Yuan's eyes widened with shock when he saw the demon, as it did not give him the feeling of an artificial demon.

'The demon... It's a real demon!? They're going to use a real demon for this event?! This is insane!' Yuan cried inwardly when he realized that they would be using a real demon for the tournament.

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Chapter 813 - Real Demon Emperor

Yuan nearly jumped out of his seat when he realized that they were going to use a real demon instead of an artificial demon during this event.

"This is pure insanity! What if something goes wrong and the demon escapes? That would be catastrophic!" He cried inwardly.

However, the other people there had a different response.

"Wow, what a strong-looking demon. What rank do you think it is?" Lian Er mumbled to herself, clearly more intrigued than terrified of its existence.

"It should be at least a Demon General, right?" Lian Li said.

"It's hard to tell since the demon has its aura restrained by those red chains, but I doubt it would be anything lesser than a Demon General. After all, this is also an exam for these Master Demon Sealers." Lian San responded.

Once the demon was revealed, Qian Chu spoke in a clear voice, "The first one to seal or kill this demon will become the next Supreme Demon Sealer. I will remove the final seals on the demon in ten seconds."

The five participants quickly spread out and surrounded the demon.

Even though they were competing against each other, they also knew how risky it was to try and fight the demon alone.

Their best option at the moment would be to fight the demon together and slowly seal the demon, saving their energy before trying to get the last hit.

While everyone waited for the ten seconds to pass, the demon used this time to analyze its surroundings and situation.

"A bunch of lowly humans dare to use this one for entertainment? I will tear all of your limbs and drink your blood for this offense." The demon showed a malicious smile on its face, and it did not seem worried even in the slightest despite its seemingly hopeless situation.

Ten seconds passed in the blink of an eye, and Qian Chu waved his sleeves when the ten seconds were up, removing the red chains that had been suppressing the demon's power this entire time.

The second the red chains disappeared, the demon released a deafening roar, and an immensely powerful aura erupted from its body, sweeping the place with intense killing intent that immediately shocked the spectators.

When Yuan felt the killing intent for the first time, his body froze from shock, and he even lost his ability to breathe.

'W-What is this killing intent?! What is this bloodthirsty aura?! I have never experienced anything like this before!' Yuan cried inwardly, and he could feel his instincts screaming at him to run away from the scene as soon as possible.

It felt like he was before the grim reaper itself, and that death was right in front of him.

However, he resisted such urges and even bit on his lips until it began bleeding, using pain to keep himself sane.

"A-Are you okay?" Lian Er noticed Yuan's condition and asked him despite being affected by the demon's killing intent herself, as her whole body was shivering nonstop.

"Y-Yes..." He responded in a mosquito-like voice.

While under this intense stress that challenged him mentally and physically, pushing him to his limits, something began changing within Yuan.

Meanwhile, the five participants immediately began their assault on the demon the second it was released from its bindings.

They all released their demon sealing technique simultaneously at the demon, but the demon quickly reacted and used a movement technique to dodge it.

However, it was unable to dodge all of the demon sealers' attack, only successfully dodging three of them.

[Demon Sealing Pulse!]

Yan Hara pushed her palm forward, sending a powerful wave of demon sealing aura at the demon, hitting it directly in its chest and blowing a hole in its body.

The demon, of course, healed its wound almost immediately, and it didn't seem to be affected by the demon sealing aura.

Yan Hara did not panic at the result and continued her assault on the demon with the other demon sealers.

Before a minute has even passed, the five demon sealers managed to hit the demon with over a dozen demon sealing techniques, yet the demon continued to move around as though it was unaffected by demon sealing aura.

"This demon is definitely a Demon Emperor..." Lian Er sighed.

And she continued, "If not for the Leader's presence, I would be too scared to even stay here and watch this..."

'This is the prowess of a real Demon Emperor?' Yuan thought to himself, still struggling to keep calm while enduring the demon's intense aura.

Although the demon's killing intent was very powerful, it was actually not something Yuan couldn't handle. Instead, it was the demon's cultivation aura that Yuan couldn't endure.

He was only a Spirit Lord while the demon was most likely above Spirit Sovereign— it was at a level that he didn't even have knowledge of, and it could be considered a miracle that he was remaining conscious even under such intense pressure.

"AHAHAHAHA! I am not the one entertaining you humans, it's the other way around! Continue to entertain me, and I will allow you to live a little longer!" The Demon Emperor laughed out loud as it continued to eat up demon sealing techniques without any fear in its eyes.

A few minutes later, the Demon Emperor eventually got bored of being attacked, so it started attacking the demon sealers.

"Bloody Impalement!"

The Demon Emperor's body suddenly shot out hundreds of arm-sized needles made out of its own blood like a grenade, sending these needles all over the place.

The five demon sealers immediately halted their offense and went into defense, trying their best to deflect these needles, but they were not able to remain unscathed at the end, suffering above minor injuries.

"Is that all you've got?! It appears to me that demon sealers have gotten much weaker since that bastard's death!" The Demon Emperor laughed out loud.

"Shut up! The Divine Paragon was never confirmed dead! He's still missing!" Yan Hara rebuked.

"Whatever makes you sleep at night, human." The Demon Emperor turned to look at her with a mocking grin on its face.

"The stench of demons, it never changes..."

Lian Er turned to look at Yuan when she heard him mumbling something, "Huh? What did you just say?"

Although it might just be her, she felt that something was off about Yuan—like something about him had suddenly changed.

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Chapter 814 - Demon Sealing Flag

Yuan turned to look at Lian Er and responded in a calm voice, "It's nothing. Oh, can you tell me about the current leader of the Demon Sealing Clan?"

"T-The leader?" Lian Er was slightly taken aback by his weird question that had nothing to do with the current event.

"Well... What do you want to know about him?" Despite shivering all over her body, Lian Er wanted to remain respectful and decided to entertain him.

"Any information is fine. Just tell me everything you know about him." Yuan said.

'He's no longer trembling? Did he already adapt to the Demon Emperor's aura? No... that's not possible. He's only a Spirit Lord, and it has only been a few minutes since the event started. Just how is he doing it?' Lian Li wondered to herself as she watched their conversation.

Yuan, who had been terrified out of his mind just moments ago, suddenly appeared to be completely fine under the Demon Emperor's aura.

Lian Li looked around her at the other spectators, and sure enough, most of them were still trying to adapt to the Demon Emperor's ridiculous aura, so how is a Spirit Lord like Yuan completely fine?

Lian San also noticed Yuan's odd state and thought to himself, 'He's not an ordinary demon sealer. No wonder why a Spirit Lord like him dared to come to this place...'

While her siblings wondered about Yuan's identity, Lian Er spoke, "I don't actually know that much about the leader, so sorry in advance if I wasn't of any help."

"Anyways, the current leader is, as you already know, the 8th leader of the Demon Sealing Clan. He's been with the Demon Sealing Clan for over 100,000 years, and he took over the clan after the previous leader died in an accident."

"As for his qualifications, he has sealed over 20 demons and killed 7 demons, making him the most experienced demon sealer in the clan."

"He became a Master Demon Sealer after spending just a little over 1,000 years in the Demon Sealing Clan, a Supreme Demon Sealer 5,000 years later, and he went on to become the leader of the clan about 10,000 years later, becoming the youngest leader of the Demon Sealing Clan in history."

"Because of him, the declining Demon Sealing Clan also regained some of its strength, so the Grand Elders rewarded him with the Demon Sealing Flag, one of the most powerful demon sealing treasures out there that was once used by the Divine Paragon himself."

"Do you see that black and red flag by his side? That's the Demon Sealing Flag, one of three demon sealing treasures that was once owned by the Divine Paragon. Rumor has it that the Divine Paragon has sealed over 1,000 demons with it."

"The Demon Sealing Flag, huh?" A mysterious smile appeared on Yuan's face as he looked at the majestic flag standing proudly beside Qian Chu.

"Where are the other two treasures?" Yuan asked next.

"I'm not really sure since they always keep its whereabouts a secret, but rumor has it that the Demon Sealing Grotto has them." Lian Er said.

"The Demon Sealing Grotto?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

Lian Er nodded, "When some of the most trusted demon sealers left the Demon Sealing Clan and created the Demon Sealing Grotto, they took with them one of the Divine Paragon's treasures. As for the second one, I was told that the Demon Sealing Clan had to surrender it to the Demon Sealing Grotto during its lowest point when it was on the brink of destruction in

order to save the clan. However, these are just rumors without any solid evidence to support it, so you shouldn't consider them to be true."

Yuan released a low sigh after hearing such information, "How the Demon Sealing Clan has fallen..."

'Although I didn't really care about the Demon Sealing Clan even up to my death, it still leaves a bitter taste in my mouth knowing that something I personally built is slowly being destroyed.' Yuan sighed inwardly.

After being pressured past his limits by the Demon Emperor's aura, Yuan's memories as the Divine Paragon resurfaced, as did his personality as the Divine Paragon, so one can say that it was the Divine Paragon's consciousness that is currently awake in Yuan's body.

"The Demon Sealing Clan is no longer what it once was, so why did you decide to join the clan? You would've been better off joining the Demon Sealing Grotto that is much stronger nowadays." Yuan suddenly asked her.

Lian Er smiled and quickly responded without hesitation, "That's simple. Like most demon sealers nowadays, I joined the Demon Sealing Clan not for its strength but for its legacy and history."

"The Demon Sealing Clan is neither a faction nor a sect, so its prowess really doesn't matter to me. I am satisfied with being part of something that made a difference in the world. Without the Demon Sealing Clan and the Divine Paragon, I doubt we would be living so peacefully right now, much less using a Demon Emperor for entertainment."

A gentle smile appeared behind his mask after hearing Lian Er's words, and he no longer asked her any more questions.

Instead, he turned his attention to the Demon Emperor that appeared to be toying with the five Master Demon Sealers.

"They won't win against this Demon Emperor." Yuan suddenly mumbled in a low voice that could only be heard by the triplets.

"Huh? What do you mean?" They all turned to look at him with raised eyebrows.

"If they continue like this, they're all going to die— all five of them." Yuan said.

"How is that possible? All of the demon sealers in the arena are Master Demon Sealers— they're the best of the best within their rank. There's no way they'd all lose to a single demon, right?" Lian Li asked.

"You guys are underestimating the prowess of a Demon Emperor. That thing... It's just toying with them right now. Once it gets serious, only the Grand Elders and the 8th Leader can handle it.." Yuan said to them.

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Chapter 815 - Blood Sphere

"We're underestimating the Demon Emperor? You sound like you have encountered one before." They looked at Yuan with raised eyebrows.

"I guess you can say that." A smile appeared behind his mask.

"Well, I believe in them. They will definitely defeat the demon!" Lian Er said.

However, just as she said those words, the Demon Emperor suddenly released a deafening roar that shook the entire coliseum.

Yuan and the triplets immediately turned to look at the scene, and the Demon Emperor had suddenly grown a pair of bloody wings. Furthermore, the Demon Emperor grew in size, becoming twice as large compared to just mere moments ago.

Of course, its size was not the only thing that grew, as its killing intent and bloodthirsty aura also increased exponentially.

This shocked not only the spectators but the fighters as well.

None of them had expected the Demon Emperor to hide this much strength for so long.

"What's wrong, humans? Cold feet? How about I warm them up for you?!"

The Demon Emperor suddenly flew into the sky and began channeling its energy at a rapid rate.

When the fighters saw how much energy it was gathering, they immediately began preparing their defenses, as there was no way that they'd be able to

stop the Demon Emperor in time.

"Hell Rain!"

The Demon Emperor laughed out loud as it created countless weapons in the sky before sending them at the fighters.

The five demon sealers in the arena immediately used their treasures to defend against the strike, and some of them even prepared their life-saving treasures just in case their defenses failed.

The spectators gasped in shock as they watched countless weapons rain upon the five fighters, enveloping their entire figures.

They all turned to look at Qian Chu, who had a calm expression on his face, and when they saw his expression, the spectators also calmed down.

Sure enough, the fighters broke through the sea of weapons and flew into the air shortly after, but they appeared to be heavily injured, and their bodies were filled with holes and cuts.

However, despite their seemingly awful conditions, these injuries were not even close to life-threatening for these powerful cultivators.

Although they didn't have the demon's ridiculous ability to regenerate a whole body in seconds, they could easily heal these minor injuries with their spiritual energy.

After recovering from the Demon Emperor's assault, the five fighters continued their assault on the demon.

This time, the five Master Demon Sealers stopped trying to be selfish and started using all of their tricks and resources to deal with the Demon Emperor, allowing them to push it back.

"See? They are fine." Lian Er said after witnessing this.

Yuan didn't respond and continued to watch them.

However, he lost interest after a while and turned to look at Qian Chu, who was still sitting on his throne with a calm expression.

There was just something about Qian Chu that didn't feel right to him, but he couldn't pinpoint the reason, mostly because he doesn't know Qian Chu very well.

A few minutes later, when it seemed like the Master Demon Sealers were on the verge of sealing the Demon Emperor, the Demon Emperor began laughing.

"Truly pathetic. I gave you ten whole minutes, yet this is the best you can do?" The Demon Emperor mocked the fighters with a look of disdain on its face.

Afterward, it raised its right hand into the air.

'What is it trying to do now?' Yan Hara wondered to herself as she watched the Demon Emperor. This is her first time seeing such an ability, and it was giving her an ominous feeling.

The other Master Demon Sealers felt the same way.

"We cannot let it finish whatever it is trying to do! Let's forget about the tournament and just kill it!" Suo Rengan said to the other four fighters, who agreed with him.

Once they were prepared, all five fighters surrounded the Demon Emperor before unleashing their strongest demon sealing technique.

"Too slow!"

The Demon Emperor suddenly shouted, and what appeared to be a ball of blood appeared on its palm.

"Blood Sphere."

The Demon Emperor muttered in a low voice, and before any of the demon sealers could even react, the ball of blood expanded in size countless times

until it swallowed the entire arena and all of the fighters inside, blocking the spectators from seeing the situation.

"W-What the hell did it just do?!" Lian Li exclaimed in a puzzled voice.

"Blood Sphere. It's a containment technique that essentially creates an area that restricts anyone inside from leaving, and while inside this sphere, the demon's strength is increased several folds. This is a technique that can only be used by Demon Emperors, and they only use it when they are going to fight seriously." Yuan explained to them.

And he continued, "It's over for the demon sealers. They won't survive even a few minutes inside the Blood Sphere."

"N-No way... What about the Leader?! Shouldn't he stop the tournament and seal the demon before things get out of hand?" Lian Er quickly became nervous for the five demon sealers.

"Who knows." Yuan shrugged.

He then turned to look at the Demon Sealing Flag that was still fluttering beside Qian Chu and narrowed his eyes.

'I will only be able to save one of you with this...'

The very next moment, the Demon Sealing Flag that had been standing still this entire time suddenly began trembling.

When Qian Chu noticed this anomaly, he turned to look at it with a puzzled gaze.

However, before he could even do anything, the Demon Sealing Flag suddenly flew out of his hands and towards the arena.

It easily pierced a hole in the Blood Sphere and entered the Demon Emperor's territory.

Qian Chu stood up with a look of surprise on his face after seeing this, and he immediately began looking around with a deep frown on his face.

'Who?! Who is commanding my Demon Sealing Flag without my permission?!' He roared inwardly.

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Chapter 816 - Eventually

After realizing that someone was using his Demon Sealing Flag without permission, Qian Chu immediately began looking for the culprit.

Qian Chu quickly noticed a particular figure amongst the spectators, as he was the only person in the entire coliseum to be wearing a mask.

However, when Qian Chu realized that Yuan was only a peak Spirit Lord, he immediately ruled Yuan out as the culprit.

After all, there was no way that some random Spirit Lord would be able to command the Demon Sealing Flag, much less control it so flawlessly.

After he received the Demon Sealing Flag, the time it took him to control the treasure was longer than the time it took him to become the 8th leader of the Demon Sealing Clan since the moment he joined the clan.

It took him almost 30,000 years of sweat and effort to control the Demon Sealing Flag, which is twice as long as it took him to become the 8th leader, so it would only be natural for him to rule Yuan out as the culprit.

If a mere Spirit Lord could control the Demon Sealing Flag, it would make a mockery out of his 30,000 years of effort.

Once Qian Chu ruled out Yuan as the culprit, he immediately returned to looking for the culprit, completely ignoring the situation between the Demon Emperor and the fighters.

Meanwhile, inside the Blood Sphere, right after being trapped inside, Yan Hara and the others tried to break the blood barrier but quickly realized that was impossible.

"None of you will be leaving my Blood Sphere alive today." The Demon Emperor laughed at their attempts to escape.

"Don't panic! The Grand Elders and the Demon Sealing Clan's Leader are still watching us! They won't let us die!" Yan Hara said to the others when she noticed the worried looks on their faces.

Yan Hara's words worked perfectly, as the others immediately calmed down after being reminded that they were not alone.

"You foolish demon. If we dared to release you, it means we are confident in sealing you away whenever we want! You demons might have ruled the Nine Heavens before, but time has changed! Demons are no longer a threat, and cultivators nowadays are far stronger than before! You demons wouldn't survive this era even if the Divine Paragon isn't here!" Suo Rengan said out loud.

However, instead of being provoked, the Demon Emperor laughed out loud and said, "The world may be different nowadays, but you demon sealers are definitely much weaker than before."

"Also, you should stop taking others' credit."

Suo Rengan frowned and said, "Huh? The fuck are you talking about? How am I stealing others' credit?"

"Do you really think humans defeated us, demons, back then? Negative. We didn't lose to humanity. We lost to a monster—the Bane of Demons, Divine Paragon! Although his demon sealing techniques are annoying and have the ability to seal us, the techniques alone would not be enough to defeat us!"

"Sure, there were a few prominent human cultivators that managed to kill a couple of demons back then, but they were all insignificant when compared to the Divine Paragon's achievement. Alone, he slaughtered more demons than all of humanity combined. Therefore, you should stop acting like demons were defeated by humans. It was a monster that defeated us—a single one." The Demon Emperor's voice sounded a little shaky when speaking about the Divine Paragon.

The demon sealers were left speechless by the Demon Emperor's words.

And before they could respond, the Demon Emperor continued to speak with a mysterious smile on its face, "However, now that the Divine Paragon is dead, it will only be a matter of time before demons rule the Nine Heavens again."

"That will never happen! Demons are almost extinct! Even if you gathered all of the demons that are still alive in this world, the best you would be able to do is run!" Jiang Ziya exclaimed.

The Demon Emperor started laughing again, "Sure, there may only be a few demons left in this world, but let me ask you this..."

"Where do we, demons, come from?"

None of the demon sealers were able to answer the Demon Emperor's question, so they remained silent.

"I will give you a hint. The Demonic Realm."

"Are you saying that more demons will come from the Demonic Realm? That's impossible! The Divine Paragon sealed it!" Yan Hara exclaimed.

"The keyword is 'sealed'." The Demon Emperor smiled.

"Once a demon is sealed, do they remain sealed forever? No, they will eventually break out of their seal. Even if it might take them 10 million years to do so, the seal is not permanent. If you truly want to get rid of a demon, you must destroy us."

"As for the Demonic Realm, it was only sealed, not destroyed, and even the Divine Paragon was not able to destroy it, so there will be a day when that seal goes away, and when that happens, the Nine Heavens will be ruled by demons once again!"

Upon hearing the Demon Emperor's words, Yan Hara refuted, "Even if the Demonic Realm is unsealed one day, it won't matter! The Divine Paragon killed most of the demons within the Demonic Realm before sealing it, and

as far as I'm aware, you demons cannot procreate, so there won't be more demons as time passes!"

"Were you inside the Demonic Realm with the Divine Paragon? Did you witness him killing the demons inside? I don't think so."

"And while it's true that we cannot reproduce..."

The Demon Emperor suddenly showed them a chilling smile.

"There are actually ways for us to increase our numbers."

"What?!" Yan Hara and the others were terrified to hear such information. If what the Demon Emperor said was true, it would be catastrophic for the Nine Heavens once the Demonic Realm is unsealed!

The Divine Paragon sealed the Demonic Realm many millions years ago, so the demons would have plenty of time to increase their numbers!

"Don't think too much about it. You'll all be dead very shortly, after all.."
The Demon Emperor began approaching the five demon sealers with a bloodthirsty smile on its face.

Chapter 817 - Bloody Carnage

When the Demon Emperor began approaching them, Yan Hara and the other four demon sealings immediately readied their treasures to fight it.

However, the Demon Emperor sealed their movements before they could even move with a sudden outburst of killing intent that surpassed anything it had released before.

While killing intent normally paralyzes those affected by it most of the time, if strong enough, one could even kill another using purely just killing intent, as there's only so much stress and pressure one's heart could endure before something goes horribly wrong.

When the five demon sealers experienced the Demon Emperor's intense killing intent, they all coughed up a mouthful of blood, and their instincts screamed for them to run away, but their bodies did not listen to their commands, almost as though their connections had been severed by their fear of the Demon Emperor.

"Today, I shall let you experience despair and death."

The Demon Emperor said to them before taking a deep breath.

"Bloody Carnage."

After uttering these chilling words, the Demon Emperor suddenly exploded into a bloody mess, shocking the demon sealers.

However, the Demon Emperor did not regenerate like it normally would. Instead, it would form into a ball of blood that hovered in the air.

Although the demon sealers had no idea what the Demon Emperor was trying to do, they had a very bad feeling about it.

It was at this moment a hole opened up in the Blood Sphere, and a red and black flag flew inside, landing right beside Yan Hara.

"Wha—"

Before she could even wonder what the Demon Sealing Flag was doing there, the Demon Sealing Flag wrapped its flag around her body.

"W-What's going on?! Hey!"

Yan Hara subconsciously began struggling to break free, but it was no use, as the Demon Sealing Flag had completely restrained her.

The other four demon sealers were left dumbfounded by this sudden event, but they had no time to ponder about it, as the Demon Emperor would strike a moment later.

The ball of blood that had been hovering about 25 meters away from the demon sealers suddenly began expanding exponentially.

In just mere seconds, the ball of blood had expanded over 10 times until it covered almost the entire arena.

The demon sealers beside Yan Hara immediately rushed to the end of the Blood Sphere and tried to break out. Whatever the Demon Emperor was up to, they did not want to be part of it, but the Blood Sphere was incredibly durable, and not even their strongest treasures could create a hole in the wall of blood that confined them.

"Leader! Help us! Leader Qian!" Jiang Ziya, who belonged to the Demon Sealing Grotto, screamed out loud for help.

"I quit! Get me out of here! If any of us dies here today, the Demon Sealing Grotto will not let this go!" Zu Ti, who was also part of the Demon Sealing Grotto also screamed for Qian Chu's help.

However, there was no response from the Grand Elders or Qian Chu.

Outside the Blood Sphere, Elder Cen looked at Qian Chu with a frown and spoke, "There's something wrong. We should stop this event and restrain the Demon Emperor before someone gets hurt or worse— die."

Qian Chu, who was still looking for the person who used the Demon Sealing Flag, stopped and looked at Elder Cen with a calm yet sharp gaze.

"Of course, we can stop the event. However, that would mean the Demon Sealing Grotto is not confident in their own demon sealers."

The frown on Elder Cen's face grew deeper, and he responded, "And you believe that the Demon Sealing Clan's demon sealer would be able to defeat that Demon Emperor?"

Qian Chu smiled, "I wouldn't have allowed them to participate if I wasn't confident in their abilities."

Elder Cen continued to stare at Qian Chu for a few more seconds before turning to look at the Blood Sphere with a contemplating face.

"I will stop the event." Qian Chu suddenly said.

But as he began moving towards the Blood Sphere, Elder Cen spoke, "Wait."

And he continued, "Let's wait a little longer before we make any move. They have plenty of life-saving treasures, so they won't die even against a Demon Emperor."

Qian Chu didn't say anything else and returned to his seat.

Meanwhile, inside the Blood Sphere, the demon sealers were desperately crying for help.

"Damn it! Why are none of my teleport talismans working?!" Shen Yue of the Demon Sealing Grotto exclaimed in a stressed tone when her talismans

failed to activate no matter how much spiritual energy she poured into them.

"It must be due to this damn thing containing us! We need to get out of here as soon as possible!" Jiang Ziya said.

"Continue attacking the wall! I don't believe that we cannot break through!" Suo Rengan shouted.

"Fuck! Qian Chu! What the fuck are you doing?! Hurry up and save us!" Zu Ti cursed out loud.

"This must be a trap the Demon Sealing Clan has set for us! I knew we couldn't trust these bastards!" Shen Yue began shedding tears due to their situation.

"That's bullshit! If this is a trap, then what am I doing here?! There's also Yan Hara! And the Leader wouldn't do such a thing!" Suo Rengan refuted her claims and defended Qian Chu's honor.

After all, why would the Demon Sealing Clan sacrifice two of their most talented Master Demon Sealers just to kill three people from the Demon Sealing Grotto?

Although the Demon Sealing Clan and the Demon Sealing Grotto's relationship has worsened lately, it wasn't at the point where the leader of the Demon Sealing Clan would sacrifice his own people to get back at the Demon Sealing Grotto— at least it shouldn't!

"I don't care what you say! The Demon Sealing Grotto will—" Before Shen Yue could even finish her sentence, the ball of blood that was now the size of a small mountain suddenly exploded, sending millions of small but deadly projectiles all over the arena with each of these projectiles deadly enough to kill a Spirit King instantly.

Chapter 818 - Final Nail In The Coffin

When the Demon Emperor suddenly exploded with countless deadly projectiles, the four demon sealers could only rely on their life-saving treasures to save their lives.

Fortunately for them, their life-saving treasures did not require manual activation, and it would activate automatically when it senses danger for the holder.

Right before the projectiles would hit the demon sealers, their life-saving treasures activated, shielding them from the projectiles.

Tens of thousands of tiny yet sharp needle-shaped projectiles clashed with the demon sealers' life-saving treasures.

The demon sealers released a sigh of relief when they realized that their life-saving treasures had activated just in time, but when they noticed cracks appearing on their life-saving treasures, they would suck in a breath of cold air, and they prayed inwardly that the life-saving treasures would endure the abuse.

"Ah!"

A painful cry suddenly resounded, causing the demon sealers to subconsciously look at the direction.

To their shock, Zu Ti's life-saving treasure had shattered, and his body was riddled with tiny holes.

However, despite sustaining such a grievous injury, Zu Ti's second life-saving treasure activated just in time, preventing him from instant death.

Unfortunately, his second life-saving treasure would not last long, and the other demon sealers were too busy defending themselves to help him.

In the end, Zu Ti of the Demon Sealing Grotto falls lifelessly onto the ground.

"Qian Chu! I swear to god! You will pay for this!" Jiang Ziya released a deafening roar after witnessing his friend's death.

As for Yan Hara, she was completely unharmed due to the Demon Sealing Flag protecting her.

In fact, the Demon Emperor's attacks ignored her completely. Because of the Demon Sealing Flag's presence and divine aura, the Demon Emperor feared that it would only harm itself by touching it, as the projectiles were essentially its own body.

Once the Demon Emperor's assault ended and there were no more projectiles to shoot, the projectiles that had been released began gathering again, quickly returning to being a ball of blood.

Soon, the Demon Emperor launched a second wave of Bloody Carnage, destroying the demon sealers' exhausted life-saving treasures.

Though, just like Zu Ti, they had more than one life-saving treasure, allowing them to survive once again.

However, the Demon Emperor did not stop and continued to launch attacks on the demon sealers.

The demon sealers were frustrated and filled with despair, but there was nothing they could do in this situation.

They could barely protect their own lives, so it was impossible to try and stop the Demon Emperor. Even if they could attack the Demon Emperor, they were clearly not capable of defeating it.

Therefore, these demon sealers could only wait for rescue while their life-saving treasures quickly disappear one after another.

A minute later, Shen Yue ran out of life-saving treasures after her fourth one broke.

She turned to look at the other two with a pleading gaze, "Please! Help me! That was my last life-saving treasure!"

"S-Sorry, but this is also my last one..." Jiang Ziya turned his head to avoid eye contact.

Suo Rengan didn't even say anything and acted like he didn't hear her.

Seeing this, Shen Yue turned around and began banging on the bloody wall with all of her strength.

"Help me! Elder Cen! Please! I don't want to die here—"

Unfortunately, before she could even finish her sentence, the Demon Emperor launched its fifth attack.

Shen Yue's body would fall onto the ground the next moment, her body filled with holes.

"Fuck! Fuck! Fuck! Why is this happening?!" Jiang Ziya began cursing and crying at the same time.

He could've never expected such a dreadful situation would occur when he signed up for this tournament! In fact, he didn't even know that he would be fighting a Demon Emperor until the moment it was revealed to him!

The last tournament only required the previous participants to fight a Demon General, so why did they have to fight a Demon Emperor?! It didn't make any sense!

"..."

When Jiang Ziya saw that the Demon Emperor was preparing for its next attack, he released a low sigh, as his last life-saving treasure was on the verge of being destroyed. His hope for survival quickly diminished until there was none left, and he turned to look at Suo Rengan with a calm expression.

"Congratulations. The Demon Sealing Clan has just secured the final nail in its own coffin. Once the Demon Sealing Grotto learns of our death, they will finally have a reason to remove the Demon Sealing Clan once and for all."

Suo Rengan did not respond to Jiang Ziya's words, mostly because he was too focused on the Demon Emperor to actually hear Jiang Ziya's words properly.

The next moment, Jiang Ziya would also fall to the Demon Emperor's attack when his final life-saving treasure was destroyed.

Meanwhile, outside the Blood Sphere, Grand Elder Cen could no longer ignore the unpleasant feeling in his guts and said, "That's it! Stop the event! Something is clearly wrong here!"

"Alright." Qian Chu did not refuse.

They stood up the next moment and flew into the arena together. When Grand Elder saw this, he followed them.

The spectators then watched as Qian Chu and the Grand Elders worked together to tear a hole in the Blood Sphere.

While they worked on destroying the Blood Sphere, Qian Chu would try to command the Demon Sealing Flag to return to him, but alas, it would not listen to him for some reason.

Although he did not show it on his face, Qian Chu was incredibly frustrated by this.

"Scatter!"

Qian Chu used his anger to strike the Blood Sphere, instantly tearing it wide open, allowing everyone to see the situation inside again.

However, when the spectators saw the scene and the corpses inside the arena, they all gasped in shock, clearly filled with disbelief.

Grand Elder Cen immediately fumed with anger when he realized that all three members of the Demon Sealing Grotto were dead, but he didn't start pointing fingers just yet, as there was a bigger problem at hand— the Demon Emperor.

"Once this is over, I demand an explanation, Qian Chu!" Grand Elder Cen roared at him before flying straight at the Demon Emperor that was preparing its sixth strike.

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Chapter 819 - Blood Separation

Qian Chu didn't show any reactions to Grand Elder Cen's words, and he focused on the Demon Emperor that was ready to release its next attack.

"Demon Sealing Formation!"

Grand Elder Suo suddenly created a massive formation around the arena just in time, halting the Demon Emperor's attack for a brief moment.

During this moment, Grand Elder Cen retrieved his treasure that radiated with demon sealing aura.

"Bastard! How dare you kill my people!" He shouted in anger as he unleashed a devastating attack that sliced the ball of blood in half.

The next second, the Demon Emperor regenerated until it returned to its original state, and it lifted its head to look at Grand Elder Cen and the others.

"I don't know what went through your heads that made you believe it would be a good idea to set me free, but I must thank you for releasing me." The Demon Emperor said to them with a calm smile on its face.

"If I restrained you once, I can do it again." Qian Chu responded.

"I'd like to see you try."

The Demon Emperor released a powerful roar that shook the entire coliseum, and its body began burning red, almost like it had just came out of a forge. Furthermore, its bloody wings made a complete transformation, turning into two large and long crystal shards.

The Demon Emperor's bizarre transformation baffled the spectators, as they have never seen such a sight before.

"W-What in heaven's name is that appearance? I didn't know demons can do that..." Lian Er muttered in a dazed voice, and her body that had recently calmed down started trembling in fear again.

Yuan responded almost instantly, "Those two red shards in its back are its demon crystal."

"What?! Why are they so huge? They are usually only the size of a fist-sized rock!" Lian Li exclaimed.

"Demon Emperors are almost an entirely different entity even when compared to other demons. I'm actually surprised that the 8th Leader managed to restrain this demon with his power." Yuan said.

In his mind, he was wondering if the Demon Emperor had allowed Qian Chu to restrain it on purpose for some reason.

"Pointless." Qian Chu spoke in a low voice before retrieving a black sword with red engravings on its blade.

"Demon Sealing Strike."

Qian Chu's movements were so quick that nobody in the spectators had managed to see it with their eyes, and before anyone could even realize what had happened, the Demon Emperor's body disintegrated into countless pieces until there was nothing left.

The people there were left speechless by how easily Qian Chu had managed to dispose of the Demon Emperor.

"As expected of the Demon Sealing Clan's number one genius... He killed the Demon Emperor so easily..."

The spectators began praising Qian Chu afterward.

"That was my first time seeing someone combine demon sealing aura with Sword Qi so efficiently! It's so powerful!" Lian Er's face showed admiration for Qian Chu after witnessing his prowess.

However, while everyone celebrated, Yuan shook his head inwardly.

'What an idiot.'

He then stood up and began leaving the coliseum.

"H-Hey, where are you going?" Lian Er asked him when she noticed him leaving.

"The event is done, so I have no reason to stay, and I am a little hungry." Yuan said to her before disappearing from their sights.

Grand Elder Cen descended in front of the deceased demon sealer from the Demon Sealing Grotto after Qian Chu dealt with the Demon Emperor, and he would stare at their lifeless bodies and their destroyed life-saving treasures with a dazed face.

'If I had intervened sooner, perhaps you might still be alive... I should have listened to my guts earlier.'

It was at this moment the Demon Sealing Flag released Yan Hara, who immediately began panicking.

However, when she couldn't see the Demon Emperor anywhere and saw the situation, she sighed in relief.

"T-Thank you, Leader, for saving my life." Yan Hara said to him, as she was shocked to see three corpses right beside her, mistaking Qian Chu to be her savior, which was a logical thought, since he owned the Demon Sealing Flag that protected her.

As for Suo Rengan, he'd also managed to survive because of the superior life-saving treasures his family and Grand Elder Suo gave him.

Although the other fighters had no idea that they would be fighting a Demon Emperor, Suo Rengan, who was Grand Elder Suo's grandson, had such information, allowing him to prepare in advance.

Qian Chu didn't say anything and merely nodded his head. He suspected Yan Hara to be the culprit at first, but after seeing her condition, he ruled her out.

'Who would dare steal my Demon Sealing Flag just to save her?' Qian Chu wondered to himself afterward.

Once the place calmed down, Grand Elder Cen turned to look at Qian Chu and said, "You will be hearing from the Demon Sealing Grotto soon!"

He disappeared from the coliseum shortly after, taking with him the three demon sealers' corpses.

Meanwhile, a couple of miles away from the Grand Coliseum, Yuan stopped walking when he sensed something.

"Come out. You may be able to fool those idiots, but I can smell your stench from miles away." Yuan said out loud despite it being empty there.

"..."

There was no response.

Yuan sighed and tried again, "I know that you're extremely vulnerable right now because you just used 'Blood Separation', but as you can see, I am only a Spirit Lord. You can easily kill me if you want to. I just want to talk."

After a moment of silence, Yuan shook his head, "Guess I'll just go ahead and let the others know that you're still alive."

He turned around and began walking back to the coliseum.

But before he could even take three steps, Yuan suddenly tilted his head to the right, avoiding a red projectile that shot right through where his head had just been.

He turned around to see a blob of blood sitting not far away from him, and he smiled, "Let's talk, shall we?"

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Chapter 820 - Do You Still Think I Am Dead?

"Talk? I have nothing to say to a human." The Demon Emperor's voice suddenly resounded inside Yuan's head.

"That's odd. You had plenty to say before when you were fighting the demon sealers."

"..."

After a moment of silence, the Demon Emperor asked him in a puzzled voice, "You're not scared of me? You're just a mere Spirit Lord. I have killed tens of thousands of cultivators like you without breaking a sweat before. What are you thinking, approaching me? I may be weakened right now due to Blood Separation, but I still have more than enough strength to kill you even in my current state."

The Demon Emperor was intrigued by Yuan's actions that did not make sense.

"Like I said, I only wanted to talk. It's been a while since I last had a proper conversation with a demon like you." Yuan said.

And he continued, "You know, when I first saw you in the arena, I had a feeling that I had seen you before. Now that I think about it, there was one demon back then that had the same characteristic as you. What was his name again? Demon Emperor 'Carnage'?"

The blob of blood visibly trembled after hearing its name come from Yuan's mouth.

"Y-You... Who are you? Why do you know my demon name?" The Demon Emperor exclaimed in a dazed voice.

It has been countless years since it last heard of its own demon name.

Yuan didn't answer the Demon Emperor's question and continued to speak, "There were nine of you in the beginning, but most of the Demon Emperors perished during that big fight between the Demon Sealing Clan and the Demon Clan. Near the end of that fight, three of you fled from the battlefield."

"The Demon Sealing Clan searched for you demons for thousands of years, but their efforts were unfruitful, and even the Divine Paragon was unable to find you. However, after millions of years, you suddenly show up in the most awkward fashion."

"I know you're stronger than the current Leader of the Demon Sealing Clan, so I can only assume that you'd allowed yourself to be restrained for some reason. You even went through the efforts of faking your own death... Why?"

"A pretty good topic, right? Let's begin with where you demons had hid after fleeing from the fight."

"..."

The Demon Emperor was left speechless by Yuan's story, and it could not comprehend where Yuan could've heard such a thing from, as such information should've disappeared with the passage of time.

After all, millions of years have passed since the fight. Even if the Demon Sealing Clan had recorded the information somewhere, it would require a miracle for that record to last for so long.

"Where did you hear such a thing? It's clearly bullshit." The Demon Emperor decided to deny Yuan's claims.

"There's no point denying it, Demon Emperor Carnage. If you tell me where you hid, I will tell you how I learned such information." Yuan said.

However, the Demon Emperor remained silent.

"Fine, if you don't want to answer this question, we can try another question." Yuan said, treating it almost like an interview of sorts.

"Are the other two Demon Emperors still alive? I know demons are truly immortal in the sense that they can live until the end of time if nobody tries to kill them, but nothing will last forever."

Once again, the Demon Emperor remained quiet.

Yuan didn't mind it and continued to ask the Demon Emperor questions.

In the end, the Demon Emperor refused to answer any of his questions.

"Quite the uncooperative one, aren't you?" Yuan chuckled casually, acting completely calm before the Demon Emperor that could attack him at any moment.

"Since you don't want to answer any of my questions, I will have to try and answer them by myself."

After taking a deep breath, Yuan continued, "After fleeing from that fight, you and the other two Demon Emperors probably fled to one of the forbidden zones since most cultivators avoid those places like it's a plague, and even peak cultivators don't dare to approach these zones due to its dangerous environment that can instantly kill even an Immortal, but since you're demons, you don't have to worry about dying, making the forbidden zones the best sanctuary for demons."

"If I have to make a gamble on whether there are currently more demons in these forbidden zones or not, I would bet all of my money on the former."

"In fact, I would even dare to say that most of the demons that still exist can be found in these forbidden zones. If the Demon Sealing Clan, or any

family with sufficient powers find out, they will surely do whatever it takes to get rid of demons once and for all."

"Now, let's talk about—"

Yuan suddenly halted his words and activated his movement technique, dodging a sudden sneak attack from the Demon Emperor.

The blob of blood also started transforming, and the Demon Emperor returned to its original appearance the next moment.

"I don't know who you are or what you want, but I cannot allow you to live for another minute." The Demon Emperor glared at Yuan with serious killing intent in its gaze.

"Are you sure you want to do that? What will you do if the others notice your presence and find you? You'll definitely die this time, especially since you're in that pathetic state." Yuan asked.

"Even if I die today, I will make sure to take your life first."

The Demon Emperor used Blood Sphere to contain Yuan the next moment. It was clearly prepared to sacrifice its life to make sure that Yuan wouldn't reveal the demon's sanctuary.

Seeing the Blood Sphere around him, Yuan smiled behind his mask and spoke in a calm voice, "To tell you the truth, I already knew that you demons were hiding within the forbidden zones. I was just too lazy to do anything about it, and my supply of demon cores was filled to the brim after that battle, so I didn't chase you lots."

"What...?" The Demon Emperor's eyes widened with shock after hearing Yuan's words, as he sounded like someone it knew... and feared.

Yuan removed his mask a moment later, revealing his handsome face and the cold smile on it.

"Do you still think I am dead?" Yuan suddenly asked the Demon Emperor, who was completely frozen from shock after the reveal.

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Chapter 821 - What Is The Meaning Of This?

"Y-You... I-Impossible!" Demon Emperor Carnage immediately recognized Yuan's face, as it saw the same face during the war between demons and the Demon Sealing Clan, and after almost dying to him, it fled to one of the forbidden lands within the Nine Heavens.

It was also confident that the Divine Paragon had long perished, hence why it finally decided to come out of hiding. However, to think that it'd encounter the Divine Paragon once again.

The Demon Emperor eventually snapped out of its daze when it realized that the Divine Paragon looked slightly different than before.

"You may look like him, but you're not the Divine Paragon! I must say, you nearly gave me a heart attack. It has been tens of millions of years and many eras since the Divine Paragon's disappearance. No humans can live for that long!"

"Even though cultivators can technically become immortal, they are not truly immortal! Only we, demons, are truly immortal!"

Yuan smiled at the Demon Emperor's words and said, "You're right. I perished. However, it was my own decision to 'disappear', and now, I have returned."

"That's fucking bullshit! As if I'd believe that!" The Demon Emperor refused to believe that Yuan was really the Divine Paragon.

"Valley of Blood..." Yuan suddenly muttered in a low voice.

"What?" The Demon Emperor froze again.

"Corpse Mountain... Blood Monastery... Tomb of the Ancients..."

Yuan ignored the Demon Emperor and continued to name these weird titles one by one.

"H-How do you know these names?!" The Demon Emperor suddenly roared in a confused tone.

After all, these names were all places within the Demonic Realm! No humans should know of these places since no human has ever entered that place and managed to make it back out alive— except for one exception—the Divine Paragon!

"Isn't it obvious? I learned of these places when I went inside the Demonic Realm. It was a surprise when I first went there. If the rest of the world knew what I saw inside, they would be shocked."

"I-I still don't believe it! For all I know, the Divine Paragon could've revealed information about the Demonic Realm to the world after he sealed it!"

"It's unfortunate that you don't believe me. If I could use my signature demon sealing technique to prove my identity, I would do it. However, my body and its cultivation would not be able to handle such a technique."

"Anyways, since you revealed yourself by using such a powerful technique, the others are alerted of your presence, and it will only be a matter of time before they arrive and dispose of you."

"While you are most certainly strong enough to handle the Demon Sealing Clan in their current state, you're in no condition to do anything right now because of Blood Separation. Therefore, I shall give you a proposal."

"You can either let the Demon Sealing Clan deal with you, or you can die in my hands. Which do you prefer? I promise that it will be a swift death if you choose the latter."

"Or I can kill you and leave this place before they arrive!" The Demon Emperor instantly jumped into action and flew towards Yuan.

Without even trying to dodge, Yuan casually pointed at the Demon Emperor and muttered in a low voice, "Demon Sealing Zone."

Bang!

The Demon Emperor slammed into the barrier that suddenly restrained it.

"To tell you the truth, in my current condition, I would have no chance to defeat you before you used Blood Separation, so I must thank you for giving me this chance. Once I take care of you, I will find the rest of the stray demons and take care of them as well... eventually."

"Damn you, Divine Paragon! Just like before, you appear out of the blue to threaten our existence! Unfortunately for you, things will be different this time! You may have defeated me today, but you will not defeat the Demon Clan! Soon, you will know the true power of demons, when a real Ancient steps foot into this pathetic world!" The Demon Emperor began laughing in a crazed manner.

Yuan frowned slightly after hearing the Demon Emperor's words. He isn't normally bothered by demons' provocation, but it was different this time.

"An Ancient, huh... I have never tasted a demon core belonging to an Ancient before, so this will be my first."

"Hahaha! That's right! You will tremble before the Ancient!" The Demon Emperor continued to laugh even though it knew it was moments away from being killed by the Divine Paragon.

However, to the Demon Emperor's absolute surprise, Yuan suddenly removed the Demon Sealing Zone.

"W-What is the meaning of this?" It looked at him with a look of disbelief.

"Hm? Nothing much. I have always wanted to fight an Ancient, so I am going to let you go, as that would ensure I get to fight one in the future."

"Are you serious? You're willing to put the entire Nine Heavens and every human in it at risk because of such a selfish reason? You're definitely not the Divine Paragon I know."

Yuan showed a mysterious smile and said, "Then you don't really know me, but this is a statement that can be said for pretty much everyone."

He then placed the mask back on his face, turned around, and walked out of the Blood Sphere, almost as though the blood wall didn't exist.

Once Yuan was gone, the Demon Emperor no longer lingered and deactivated the Blood Sphere and used what little power it had left to run away from the scene right before the demon sealers arrived.

"Where's the demon?! I swear I felt its presence coming from this location!"

A bunch of demon sealers including Grand Elder Suo showed up to the scene mere moments after the Demon Emperor's departure. As for Qian Chu, he'd long left the place, so he did not sense the Demon Emperor's presence.

Meanwhile, Yuan returned to the Demon Sealing Grand Library, where he would remove his mask and stand before his statue, quietly staring at it for a long period of time, which puzzled the other demon sealers there that were wondering what he was doing.

Chapter 822 - A Nasty Individual

"Because you allowed the Demon Emperor to get away, who knows how many innocent lives would be lost now. And you did this all for what...? To fight this 'Ancient' thing?" Yuan muttered in a low voice as he stared at the Divine Paragon's statue.

In his eyes, the statue suddenly turned into the real Divine Paragon, and he spoke, "Ancients are the peak of the demon race. Above Demon Emperors are Ancient Demons, but they are not true 'Ancients'. Ancients are the first demons to have ever existed, and they all possess something all lower demons desire— complete control over their emotions."

"In other words, they don't have these random destructive urges that force them to go crazy, just like us humans. A demon that can control their emotions and thoughts— they are so powerful that a single one of them could probably destroy the entire Nine Heavens."

Yuan frowned and said, "And you purposefully allowed the Demon Emperor to get away because you want to fight one of these Ancients? This is insanity and incredibly selfish! I didn't know you were such a selfish individual until now!"

The Divine Paragon smiled, "What's wrong with being selfish? Everyone is selfish in their own ways, and my selfishness is also yours. Don't forget that we are one and the same."

"I don't get it. You were the first person to start hunting demons, yet you allowed a dangerous demon like the Demon Emperor to get away today. What is your motive? Why did you start the Demon Sealing Clan and start hunting demons in the first place?"

The Divine Paragon smiled at Yuan's question and said, "If you want the answers, search for them in your memories. Defeat the fourth floor of the Demon Sealing Pagoda and you will have your answers."

"One more thing... The 8th Leader of the Demon Sealing Clan— he's a nasty individual. He intended on letting everyone at the tournament die today. I highly recommend that you stay away from him until you're strong enough to confront him, and no matter what you do, do not reveal your true identity. I have a good feeling that he will do whatever it takes to remain as the leader of the Demon Sealing Clan, so anything that threatens his position will be disposed of..."

The Divine Paragon returned to being a statue the next moment.

Yuan sighed.

There was nothing he could do right now besides to continue his training. Now that there is a Demon Emperor and two more potential Demon Emperors on the loose somewhere in the Nine Heavens, he wants to be prepared before encountering them.

Yuan went to the training area shortly after and began training his demon sealing techniques.

Now that he's completely mastered the Demon Sealing Strike, he will be moving onto other demon sealing techniques.

The following day, Yan Hara showed up at the training area to look for Yuan.

Once she found him training alone, she approached him with a smile on her face.

"Hey."

Yuan stopped training and turned to look at her.

"Senior Yan. How are you feeling?" Yuan bowed to her before asking.

"Alive," she said.

And she continued, "I'm sorry that you had to witness such a pathetic fight. I was completely useless in that fight. If not for the Leader, I would've also died to the Demon Emperor."

Yuan shook his head, "Don't feel bad, Senior. You went up against a Demon Emperor and survived. Not many people could say the same."

"I'm not sure if that makes me feel any better since I am only alive because of Leader Qian, but thank you." Yan Hara showed a bittersweet smile.

"Anyways, I have scheduled your next examination. It will be in five days. If you cannot make it, I can reschedule it for you."

"I will make it." Yuan nodded.

"By the way, who became the next Supreme Demon Sealer?" He then asked her.

Yan Hara showed a bittersweet smile before responding, "Although nobody managed to kill or seal the Demon Emperor, they decided to give it to Suo Rengan because his overall performance was better. Some people also say it's because of his background as Grand Elder Suo's grandson that gave him an advantage, but if he doesn't qualify to become a Supreme Demon Sealer, I also don't qualify."

"However, I won't let this defeat discourage me. I will definitely win the next tournament and become a Supreme Demon Sealer!" Yan Hara spoke with her fist held tightly.

"I have faith in you." Yuan said.

"You cheeky little thing. I should be the one saying such words to you! Anyways, I won't stay here for long since I still have some important business to attend to. Before I leave, I should warn you that things might get a little crazy for a bit, so you should watch out."

"What do you mean?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

Yan Hara looked around to make sure nobody was near them, and then she said in a low voice, "Because of what happened to the Demon Sealing Grotto's three demon sealers, the Demon Sealing Clan is anticipating some kind of altercation with them soon, which might lead to some fights between the demon sealers from each party, so you should be careful."

"What makes the situation even worse is that only the demon sealers from the Demon Sealing Grotto had died during the tournament, so there are people speculating that it was a trap set up by the Demon Sealing Clan to lower the Demon Sealing Grotto's power. After all, losing three Master Demon Sealers in one day is very damaging even to a powerful place like the Demon Sealing Grotto."

"If any demon sealers from the Demon Sealing Grotto try to provoke you, ignore them. If they try to start a fight, try your best to ignore them. We don't need any more drama now."

Yuan nodded, "I understand."

"Good. If anything happens within the Grand Library, you can contact me through my communication jade slip. If you are outside... Well... Good luck..."

Yan Hara left the scene shortly after warning Yuan about potential disputes between the Demon Sealing Clan and the Demon Sealing Grotto in the future.. Although everything appeared to be normal now, it was only because not everybody had heard of the situation yet, which would undoubtedly change within the next few days.

Chapter 823 - A Second Personality

After Yan Hara left, Yuan returned to training his demon sealing techniques, increasing many mastery levels for a couple of the weaker techniques, but he could not stop thinking about the Demon Emperor and the Divine Paragon's reason for letting it escape.

Even though he knew it was because the Divine Paragon wanted to fight the Ancient, he still couldn't fathom such a reasoning.

Why would the Divine Paragon risk having the demons rule the Nine Heavens again just so he could have a fight with an Ancient? Just because he is a selfish person who doesn't care about the lives of others? But the Divine Paragon wouldn't have started hunting demons in the first place if that was the case. It didn't make sense to Yuan no matter how much he pondered about it.

'I will have my answers once I defeat the fourth floor of the Demon Sealing Pagoda, but that is easier said than done...' Yuan sighed inwardly.

Even with his ridiculous talent, such a goal seemed unfathomably distant.

Unfortunately, there was nothing he could do for now except to practice.

Yuan would increase the mastery level of multiple demon sealing techniques on that day, but they were all low-ranking techniques. He wanted to completely master all the weaker techniques before focusing on the stronger ones.

At the end of the day, Yuan began making his way outside the Grand Library, but he stopped right before the exit, mostly because he was forced to stop, as there was a crowd of people that blocked the path there.

"What's going on?" Yuan asked one of the people closest to him.

"I'm not exactly sure what happened, but there are people fighting at the entrance, blocking everyone."

Yuan raised his eyebrows. Since he couldn't see the situation with his bare eyes, he decided to use his divine sense to look at the situation, and sure enough, he could see a large group of people blocking the path.

There appeared to be two sides in this large group. One of them belonged to the Demon Sealing Clan while the other group was from the Demon Sealing Grotto.

"Because of your Demon Sealing Clan's Leader's incompetence, three of our Master Demon Sealers are dead!"

"Your Grand Elder was there as well! You cannot put all the blame on us!"

"Screw you! We all know the tournament was a malicious plot by the Demon Sealing Clan to hurt our clan! Why else would they suddenly use a Demon Emperor when all previous tournaments used Demon Generals and lower ranking demons?!"

Once Yuan overheard these people arguing with each other, he immediately understood the context and why they were fighting.

Soon, the verbal argument between these two groups escalated, turning into a full fight.

The spectators there quickly scattered to give them room.

Unfortunately, most of the lecturers in the Grand Library were absent due to the same important meeting Yan Hara was attending, so there was basically nobody to stop the fighting between these two groups.

Furthermore, the fight grew bigger because the other demon sealers would join in to assist their own companions.

Very soon, half of the people within the Grand Library were fighting.

Not wanting to participate in the fight, mostly because he was the weakest cultivator in this place, Yuan went to Yan Hara's room and locked himself inside.

Of course, he had the option to log off— or so he thought.

<You cannot log off while inside an active battlefield!>

"Hopefully, the fighting doesn't last for too long." Yuan sighed as he took a seat in the empty room.

After many minutes of pure silence, a voice suddenly resounded.

"Young Master."

Feng Yuxiang appeared before him a moment later with a perplexed look on her face.

"Feng Feng? What's up?" Yuan raised his eyebrows in a puzzling manner when he saw her expression.

"Young Master... I wanted to wait until you are willing to tell us by yourself, but I simply cannot endure my curiosity any longer, and I was hoping you could answer a few of my questions... Of course, you can refuse."

"What questions?" Yuan asked.

"Well... There are times when you feel like an entirely different person. At first, I thought it was only my imagination, but after witnessing what happened today, it appears to me that you have a second personality in you..." Feng Yuxiang expressed her worries.

"Oh..." Yuan immediately realized what Feng Yuxiang was talking about.

In fact, he'd completely forgotten that Feng Yuxiang and Lan Yingying were with him this entire time, so they saw everything when he turned into the Divine Paragon.

Yuan quickly began trying to think of an excuse, but when nothing came up, he decided to tell them the truth.

"This is going to make me sound crazy, but it appears that I am the reincarnation of the Divine Paragon..." Yuan revealed the truth to them for the first time.

Feng Yuxiang's eyes widened, and she remained silent for the next few minutes, seemingly unable to find the proper words to respond to Yuan's claims.

Seeing Feng Yuxiang's reaction, Yuan quickly said, "J-Just kidding! You see, I actually—"

"It's okay, Young Master. I believe you." Feng Yuxiang suddenly interrupted.

And she continued, "I am just surprised, that's all. In case you forgot, I am a phoenix, and we symbolize immortality and resurrection, which is just another word for reincarnation. If I do not believe in reincarnation, I might as well stop being a phoenix."

"However, I must admit, I have never actually witnessed or experienced reincarnation for myself... Can you tell me why you believe that you are the reincarnation of the Divine Paragon, Young Master? You may look exactly like him, but that's not really concrete proof..."

Yuan nodded, and he said, "Sit down. This might be a long story."

Once Feng Yuxiang sat beside him, Yuan began explaining about his situation to her.

"It all started with this weird dream, where I met someone who looked exactly like me, but he was much older..."

Chapter 824 - Closed Until Further Notice

After spending many minutes explaining his situation to Feng Yuxiang, Yuan patiently waited for her response.

Feng Yuxiang spoke after digesting all of the information, "I understand why you think you are the reincarnation of the Divine Paragon now, but there's something I don't understand. You said there is someone besides the Divine Paragon who appears in your dreams?"

Yuan nodded, "Yes, and he said that I had reincarnated more than once. That is possible, right?"

"As long as one's soul isn't destroyed, they should be able to reincarnate continuously, but like I'd already said, I am not really experienced in this matter."

"Also, while there have been many people in the past that claimed to have memories of their past lives, they have never been able to prove it properly."

"Of course, that is not to say I don't believe you, but I think we should investigate your situation further before we come to any conclusions." Feng Yuxiang said.

"What do you suggest I do?"

"First of all, we need to make sure that the memories in your head are real. After all, there are techniques out there that can feed into or alter one's memories, so there is a chance that something like that happened to you."

"How can I tell if my memories are real or fake?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"There are treasures out there that can help you, but it's not going to be cheap, and even if we have enough money, I doubt we'll be able to find it in this world."

"So we just need to go to a higher heaven, right? I have been thinking about challenging the Stairway to Heaven again since I am already reaching the limits of this world." Yuan said.

"When do you intend on leaving?"

"I want to leave after Min Li finishes her disciple examination," he said.

"That quickly? You don't want to explore this world anymore?" Feng Yuxiang raised her eyebrows.

"Well, I have a lot of questions that I want to be answered, but I won't find the answers in the Spirit Heaven, so there's really no reason for me to stay there any longer."

"Fair enough." Feng Yuxiang didn't say anything else.

However, after a moment of silence, she spoke again, "By the way, Young Master, if your memories turn out to be true— that you're truly the reincarnation of the Divine Paragon, what are you going to do?"

"Nothing. I am going to continue living my life as it is. The Divine Paragon's life ended with him. I have no reason to continue his legacy, nor do I want to."

"And even if I wanted to continue his legacy, I don't even know anything about him."

"I see..."

After another moment of silence, Feng Yuxiang said, "Young Master, once we return to Spirit Heaven, let's go visit the House of Riches to see if they have the treasure required for your memories."

"Sure." Yuan nodded.

They still have two weeks until Min Li's disciple examination, anyway.

About three hours later, Yuan was finally able to log off the game.

"You're late today. Dinner just ended." Chu Liuxiang said to him after he returned to the real world.

"Sorry, but I wasn't able to log off due to some unexpected circumstances."

"Oh? Tell me about it if you want to."

Yuan nodded and told her about the situation between the Demon Sealing Clan and the Demon Sealing Grotto before they went to sleep.

Meanwhile, somewhere in Spirit Heaven, Min Li was wandering the wilderness in search of magical beasts to hunt.

After spending many minutes searching, Min Li finally encountered a first level Spirit Warrior magical beast.

However, before she could even get close to the magical beast, a powerful pressure appeared, instantly flattening the magical beast.

The excitement on Min Li's face immediately disappeared when she saw this, and she turned around to look at the small figure following her.

"How am I supposed to train if you keep killing them before I can even do anything? This is the 3rd time already! Do you hold some kind of grudge against me?" Min Li asked Xiao Hua.

"Brother Yuan told me to keep you safe." Xiao Hua said in a calm voice.

"I know he told you that, but I don't think he said anything about preventing me from training! I can handle myself, so can you just let me train properly, please? I will let you know when I need help."

After a moment of silence, Xiao Hua quietly nodded her head.

"Thank you..." Min Li returned to looking for magical beasts shortly after.

Once she found one, she turned to glare at Xiao Hua to make sure she didn't forget about their agreement.

Sometime later, she approached the magical beast and started fighting it while Xiao Hua watched from a distance.

Seeing that she could finally have some practice, Min Li fought the magical beast to the best of her abilities, and after many minutes of going back and forth, the magical beast was slain by her.

After her first kill, Min Li would spend the rest of the night hunting magical beasts, acquiring two monster cores that she would use for her cultivation once she went to the Cultivators' Haven in the nearest city.

The following day, Yuan logged into Cultivation Online after breakfast.

"Who's there?!"

The moment Yuan appeared in Cultivation Online, he was greeted by a sword that was only inches away from his neck.

"I-It's me..." Yuan responded in a nervous voice.

"Little founder? You scared me just now. How did you come inside without making a sound?" Yan Hara retrieved her sword after realizing that it was him.

"Well..."

But before Yuan could even explain, Yan Hara continued, "Anyways, are you okay? I hope you didn't participate in yesterday's fight."

"Yes, I am fine. I hid in here while everyone else fought." He nodded.

"What happened after the fight?" He then asked.

Yan Hara sighed, "Many demon sealers from both sides were injured, and someone from our side even died. In fact, the higher ups have decided to close the Grand Library for all demon sealers until further notice."

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Chapter 825 - Pill Of Truth

"What?! The Grand Library will be closed?! What about the examination? Will it be canceled as well?" Yuan asked after learning about the situation.

"No, the examination will continue as scheduled. Although the Grand Library is closed, as official lecturers, we can still enter, and we can bring other demon sealers into the Grand Library as long as you're not alone."

"So I can still learn demon sealing techniques as long as I am with you?"

"Yes."

Seeing Yan Hara nod, Yuan sighed in relief.

"However, I will be very busy for a while, so my time in the Grand Library will be very limited." Yan Hara warned him a moment later.

"I understand."

After speaking with Yan Hara, Yuan decided to leave the Grand Library and return to Spirit Heaven.

But before he left, Yan Hara asked him, "By the way, where are you coming to the Grand Library from?"

"Myriad of Techniques?" Yuan responded in a questioning tone.

"I mean where in the Nine Heavens."

"Oh, I am currently in Spirit Heaven."

"What? Spirit Heaven?" Yan Hara's eyes widened with surprise.

It was quite shocking for someone of Yuan's talent to be in Spirit Heaven. In fact, Yan Hara expected Yuan to come from no lower than the Fifth Heaven, so one can imagine her surprise after learning the truth. If only she knew that he'd actually originated from the Lower Heavens.

"What about you, Senior? Where are you from?" Yuan broke the silence and asked her.

"I'm currently in the Seventh Heaven..." She responded in a dazed voice.

"Seventh Heaven... It'll be a while before we can see each other outside of this place. Fortunately, we can see each other in this place."

"You don't need to reach the Seventh Heaven. As long as you reach the Sixth Heaven, I will be able to come to you." Yan Hara said.

"Are you sure? Won't it be expensive to go to a lower world?"

"That is only the case if I want to go below the Sixth Heaven. Things work differently once you enter the Sixth Heaven. The Lower Heaven and Spirit Heaven are relatively the same. We call these two worlds the Mortal Realm."

"The Third, Fourth, and Fifth Heaven aren't that much different from each other since their cultivators are all between Spirit King and Spirit Sovereigns with the limit being Spirit Sovereigns. Once you reach the Sixth Heaven, that is where things change drastically, as there is no longer a limit to one's cultivation level, so it won't require as many resources for me to go down there."

"I see... Thank you for the explanation. I will let you know when I reach the Sixth Heaven." Yuan said to her afterward.

"Good luck." Yan Hara nodded.

Once Yuan left the Grand Library, Yan Hara mumbled to herself, "Even with his talents, it'll probably take him a couple hundred years before he can reach the Sixth Heaven..."

Fortunately for her, who still has tens of thousands of years of longevity, a few hundred years won't mean too much to her, and if she enters seclusion, that amount of time might pass in a flash.

After leaving the Grand Library, Yuan left the Myriad of Techniques and started making his way towards the House of Riches.

A few hours later, he was standing before the auction house once again.

"I think it would make things smoother if I enter with you, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang said before appearing beside him.

Yuan nodded without saying anything since he knew that she was an expert in these situations.

The two of them approached the front door shortly after.

"Welcome to the House of Riches. How may I assist you two?"

A worker asked them when they entered the building.

Since the auction house wasn't open for business, there was nobody outside, but guests could still go there to sell their treasures there.

"We're looking for a specific treasure, and we want the auction house to help us find it." Feng Yuxiang said.

The worker looked a little dazed after hearing Feng Yuxiang's request. After snapping out of it, he spoke, "I-I'm sorry, but we don't offer that kind of service here. Right now, we're only buying treasures and accepting reservations for future auctions—"

Before the worker could even finish his sentence, a figure suddenly appeared behind him and pushed him to the side.

"W-Welcome back to our humble place, Esteemed Guest! Please ignore what this newcomer just said, he doesn't know what he's talking about. We'll be more than happy to assist you in finding your treasure." The person who just showed up said to them.

Of course, this person recognized Feng Yuxiang from the Flood Dragon's Scale auction.

The male worker that had been interrupted suddenly said with a baffled look on his face, "Cut the crap. You're the one who doesn't know what you're talking about! I have worked here way before you started!"

The female worker frowned and said, "And today will be your last day here if you continue to interrupt us. They are esteemed guests of the House of Riches, and they're friends of Senior Gu!"

The male worker's face immediately paled, and he turned to look at Feng Yuxiang and Yuan before lowering his head.

"I-I'm sorry..."

"Can we just get this over with?" Feng Yuxiang said with a nonchalant expression.

"Of course! Please, follow me. Senior Gu is absent today, so I will take care of you two." The female worker then said.

"Prepare the best tea for our guests." The female worker said to the male worker.

"Right away."

Feng Yuxiang and Yuan proceeded to follow the female worker to the best guest room in the building.

Once they sat down, the female worker asked them, "What kind of treasure are you looking for, esteemed guests?"

"We're looking for the Pill of Truth.. Do you know of it?" Feng Yuxiang asked the worker, but she didn't need a response to know the answer, as the worker had a puzzled face after hearing the pill.

Chapter 826 - Moonlight City

Indeed, the worker would shake her head the next moment and spoke, "I'm sorry, but I have never heard of the Pill of Truth before."

"You don't need to be knowledgeable about it to search for it. Honestly, I don't expect it to appear in Spirit Heaven, but I want to try." Feng Yuxiang said.

The worker nodded, "Okay, I will let Senior Gu know as soon as she returns. Oh, do you have a time limit?"

"Yes. Two weeks. If you cannot find it by then, you can forget about it."

"I understand."

Feng Yuxiang retrieved a small wooden box and placed it before the female worker.

"If you can find the Pill of Truth, I will give this to the House of Riches to show my appreciation."

"May I?"

"Go ahead."

The female worker picked up the box and opened it.

Her eyes widened with shock when she saw what was inside.

"T-This is Royal-grade Spirit Jade? Are you sure? A Spirit Jade of this size is worth over 100 million spirit stones..."

"Only if you can find the Pill of Truth." Feng Yuxiang said before taking the Spirit Jade back.

"W-We won't let you down!" The worker said with a serious face.

"Good luck." Feng Yuxiang said to her.

"Young Master, shall we leave now?" She asked him a moment later.

"Yes."

As they prepared to leave, the female worker bowed to them and said, "Once again, thank you for the Fl—"

"Ahem!"

Feng Yuxiang cleared her throat in a loud and unnatural manner, interrupting the worker.

When she looked up, she could see Feng Yuxiang staring at her with hidden killing intent in her gaze.

The female worker swallowed nervously and didn't dare to finish her sentence after seeing this.

"Feng Feng? What are you doing?" Yuan looked at her with raised eyebrows.

"N-Nothing... Let's go..." Feng Yuxiang quickly said.

Once they left the House of Riches, Feng Yuxiang asked, "What should we do now, Young Master?"

"I don't know, but we have plenty of time before the disciple examination." He shrugged.

Feng Yuxiang pondered for a moment before speaking, "Then how about I take you to the person who can remove Destiny Seals? It might be a while

before you can acquire techniques that allow you to destroy Destiny Seals, as they're quite rare."

"Let's do that." Yuan nodded.

"I don't actually know where this person is, but I know someone who does. Follow me."

Feng Yuxiang took Yuan to the teleportation device.

After traveling to a couple of different cities with the teleportation device, they arrived at Moonlight City.

"The Moonlight City is one of the smaller cities within Spirit Heaven, but they're one of the most popular ones due to their purpose. The Moonlight Brokers operate this entire city, and they're a group of people that sell or buy information for money or treasures. If you ever need information about something, you can just come here. Also, they exist in the other realms as well." Feng Yuxiang introduced the place to Yuan.

Once they were inside the city, Yuan could see why Feng Yuxiang called this city 'small', as there were many stores cramped beside each other with barely any space between each other.

"Are all of these stores brokers?" Yuan asked Feng Yuxiang as they walked the crowded street.

"Not all of them. Some of them are just regular businesses. Look at that store over there. Do you see that crescent symbol hanging on the door? That indicates the store is part of the Moonlight Brokers. All brokers in this city must have the symbol to operate, or they are selling information illegally and aren't as credible."

"I see... Hm? Why did we go to the auction house if we can just ask the people here about the Pill of Truth?" Yuan suddenly realized this.

"Although the information brokers in this place know almost everything about this world, they don't know everything, and there are resources the

House of Riches have that this city may not and vice versa. That's why it's better to visit multiple sources."

"Anyways, do you see that tall building in the distance? That is Moonlight Brokers' main building, as well as our destination."

Many minutes later, they arrived at the front of the tall building.

"That's a lot of people..." Yuan sighed when he saw the massive queue outside the place.

At this rate, it might be hours before they can even enter the building.

"Don't worry, Young Master. I have a way for us to skip the line. Stay here for a moment." Feng Yuxiang said before she started walking towards the entrance, ignoring the entire queue.

"The line is back there." The guard at the entrance said to Feng Yuxiang.

Feng Yuxiang didn't say anything and retrieved a piece of paper from her spatial ring before shoving it in the guard's face.

The guard didn't know what he was looking at, but he recognized the crescent symbol on it.

"Please wait a moment." The guard went inside the building for a minute, returning with a middle-aged man.

"Can you show what you just showed me to him?" The guard asked Feng Yuxiang.

"T-This is..."

The moment the middle-aged man saw the papers, his eyes widened with shock.

"W-Welcome back to Moonlight City, Benefactor Feng!" The middle-aged man lowered his head and bowed to her, dumbfounding the guards there, as they have never seen the middle-aged man acting in such a manner before.

"I'm here to buy information," said Feng Yuxiang in a calm voice.

"Please, follow me inside! The Boss will handle it!" The middle-aged man said.

"The Boss?!" The guards were truly shocked now.

Feng Yuxiang nodded before turning to look at Yuan and gesturing for him to go to her.

"Is everything okay?" Yuan asked.

"Yes, they have agreed to work with us." Feng Yuxiang said with a smile.

Sometime later, the middle-aged man led the two of them to the top floor before entering a luxuriously decorated room.

"Please wait a moment while I call for the Boss.." The middle-aged man bowed to them before leaving the place.

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Chapter 827 - Benefactor Feng

After leaving Feng Yuxiang and Yuan in the room, the middle-aged man rushed to the room that was only at the end of the hall.

He banged on the door and shouted, "Boss Yue! This is an emergency!"

The door flew open the next moment, and the middle-aged man rushed inside, standing before this beautiful woman with a cold expression on her face.

"What is it?"

"B-Benefactor Feng has returned!" The middle-aged man immediately said.

"Benefactor Feng? Who the heck is that?"

However, the Boss didn't appear to recognize this person.

The middle-aged man looked surprised for a second before snapping out of his daze and continuing, "Benefactor Feng! She was the person who saved Madam Yue, your mother, when she was on the verge of death! Did you already forget?! Madam Yue even told us to never forget this name even after her—"

The beautiful woman suddenly stood up with a look of realization on her face.

"W-Where is this person?!" She exclaimed.

"They're currently waiting in the guest room on this—"

Before the middle-aged man could even finish his sentence, the beautiful woman rushed outside and went to the room Feng Yuxiang and Yuan were staying in.

After opening the door in an exaggerated manner, the beautiful woman turned to look at the two figures sitting inside the room, and her gaze immediately landed on Feng Yuxiang.

"A-Are you really Benefactor Feng?" The beautiful woman asked Feng Yuxiang in a trembling voice.

"Hm? Who are you? I was expecting Yue Xin." Feng Yuxiang looked at the woman with raised eyebrows.

"I'm Yue Yin. Yue Xin, my mother, is no longer here. She passed 900 years ago..." The woman responded in a low voice.

"..."

The room turned silent for a long moment before Feng Yuxiang broke the silence and spoke, "You have my condolences."

"I heard a lot about you from my mother, Benefactor Feng. You saved my mother when she was attacked by a powerful magical beast, and you even helped the Moonlight Brokers flourish. On her deathbed, my mother told me to repay her debt to you since she was never able to." Yue Yin said.

"You don't need to repay any debts. It has been thousands of years since I left this place, and all of Yue Xin's debt has already been paid."

"What? Then why did she tell me to..."

"Don't think too much about it. Anyways, I am here today with my Young Master to buy some information." Feng Yuxiang gestured for Yue Yin to take a seat.

After a moment of silence, Yue Yin took a seat before them and spoke, "What do you want to know? Don't worry about the payment. You have

already contributed enough to the Moonlight Brokers with your generous donations before."

Feng Yuxiang nodded and spoke, "First of all, do you have any information on the Pill of Truth? We're looking for it."

"Pill of Truth? Something that precious won't exist in this world— at least I'm not aware of it." Yue Yin shook her head.

"However, I will have my people look deeper into it just in case. You should have a real response by the end of the day."

Feng Yuxiang nodded, and she continued, "As for my next request... I want to know where I can find Jia Chong."

"Jia Chong... The Wandering Array Master...?" Yue Yin held a complicated look on her face as she spoke.

"Yes." Feng Yuxiang calmly nodded.

Yue Yin sighed, "I knew things wouldn't be easy with you, but to think you want to look for Jia Chong... Do you know what happened the last time I sold information on his whereabouts? He slaughtered the people that went looking for him and destroyed nearly half of my city."

"Although Jia Chong is, without a doubt, the best Array Master in Spirit Heaven, he's also crazy. He believes that all of his encounters should be natural, and anybody that purposefully seeks out for him is trying to mess with his flow of nature— whatever that means."

Feng Yuxiang showed a confident smile on her face as she spoke, "Don't worry, I can guarantee you that he won't do anything to us."

"What about my city? He said that he'd completely erase this city if we sell him again..." Yue Yin sighed.

"We won't tell him that we found him through the Moonlight Brokers, so he won't do anything to you guys. If he does show up, you can simply deny it."

After spending many moments pondering her answer, Yue Yin finally came to a conclusion.

"Alright, we'll tell you about his whereabouts. However, the location itself is also quite dangerous. It's a place only someone insane like Jia Chong would dare traverse."

"There's only one place in Spirit Heaven that could be considered 'quite dangerous'..." Feng Yuxiang mumbled in a low voice.

"It's the Demons' Valley." Yue Yin said, confirming Feng Yuxiang's thoughts.

"D-Demons' Valley?!" Yuan exclaimed when he heard such an ominous name.

"Are there demons in this place?!" He quickly asked.

Yue Yin chuckled at Yuan's question and shook her head, "Of course not. Demons no longer exist. However, the Demons' Valley has a polluted environment that can cause people to go insane if they stay in there for too long, and the magical beasts in there are much more powerful than the ones you find everywhere else in Spirit Heaven."

"I see..."

Yue Yin then continued, "I don't know of his exact location, but I do know that he's currently in Demons' Valley."

"If you want to find him, you should go there as soon as possible since I don't know when he'll leave, but then again, he's been in that place for over a year already, way longer than he usually stays in one place."

"Thank you for the information." Feng Yuxiang said, and she turned to look at Yuan.

"What do you think, Young Master? Do you want to go now or later?"

Yuan pondered for a moment before speaking, "Let's go after my examination in a few days.. After that, we'll have an entire week to look for Jia Chong in Demons' Valley."

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Chapter 828 - Magical Beast Store

"I understand." Feng Yuxiang nodded.

Yuan turned to look at Yue Yin and asked her, "By the way, is there a Myriad of Techniques near the Demons' Valley?"

Yue Yin pondered for a moment before nodding her head, "Yes, there is a small town about 50 miles from the Demons' Valley. They have a Myriad of Techniques there."

"Thank you."

"However, I must warn you, that town is weird. Most people say it's due to the Demons' Valley that's leaking its chaotic energy outside, but there are many crazy people in that place. If you go there, try not to stay there for too long."

"I understand." Yuan nodded.

"Is there anything else you want to know about, Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang asked him.

"I have nothing else. We can leave," he said.

"Y-You're leaving already?" Yue Yin asked them.

"Yes, we have everything we need. But we'll return later for the Pill of Truth." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Unless you have something for us?"

"Well... I want to buy information from you, Benefactor Feng." Yue Yin said.

Feng Yuxiang raised her eyebrows in a questioning manner.

"What kind of information?"

"Information about my mother. I want to know about the time you spent with her."

"But I have to be with the Young Master..."

"It's okay, Feng Feng. Stay here and talk with her." Yuan quickly said.

"I'll look around the city by myself, and I still have Yingying with me. You can come back after you're done here."

"If you say so, Young Master..." Feng Yuxiang reluctantly nodded.

Thus, Feng Yuxiang stayed behind with Yue Yin while Yuan left the building by himself.

"Trust me, there isn't that much to talk about. I just happened to stumble on Yue Xin when she was in trouble and decided to save her. After that, I invested some money in the Moonlight Brokers so that I could also benefit from them. That's all." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Even then, I still want to hear about it— your time with my mother."

"Very well, but my time isn't cheap, especially when you're making me leave my Young Master's side."

Yue Yin nodded her head with a resolute face.

Feng Yuxiang sighed, and she began recalling her experience with Yue Xin to the best of her abilities, as it has been thousands of years since it happened.

Meanwhile, Yuan wandered Moonlight City aimlessly. Although it was a small city, it was incredibly active with shops left and right.

After walking for a few minutes, Yuan stopped by this store that immediately caught his interest the moment he laid eyes on it, and it was one of the biggest buildings on the street.

"Magical Beast Store?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"Yingying, do you know anything about this kind of business?" Yuan decided to ask her, who was a Divine Beast.

"Yes, there are people out there who make a living by capturing magical beasts to nurture and train before selling them to beast tamers. However, it wasn't that popular in the Mythic Realm, so it rarely happened." Lan Yingying responded.

"Beast Tamers... They are cultivators that fight with magical beasts as their companions, right? Does this make me a Beast Tamer?"

"You're technically a Beast Tamer since you have tamed two Divine Beasts, but you're nothing like a Beast Tamer since you don't ask us to fight for you, and you see us as more than just 'servants', which is something most Beast Tamers don't do."

"I see... I haven't really come across any Beast Tamers since I started cultivating. Are they that rare?"

"I'm not really sure about the Beast Tamers out here since I was born inside the Mystic Realm. However, they're not that popular within the Mystic Realm since it requires a lot of resources and effort to train a magical beast. Even if you form a contract with a magical beast, it doesn't necessarily mean that they'll listen to you."

"Furthermore, they still have to cultivate their own bodies even though their servants do most of the work. If you ask me, only wealthy cultivators would become Beast Tamers due to the amount of resources it requires."

"That makes sense..." Yuan mumbled.

In the end, Yuan's curiosity got the best of him, so he went inside the building to take a look.

'This isn't what I expected... It's quite clean in here...' Yuan thought to himself when he saw the interiors of the building.

For some reason, he expected the place to resemble an animal store, but he couldn't see any magical beasts on display.

"Hello, how may I help you?" A tall middle-aged man approached Yuan shortly after he stepped inside the store.

"I'm just looking around," he said.

"I see... Are you interested in magical beasts?" The man then asked.

"A little."

"Then have you ever thought about becoming a Beast Tamer? Beast Tamers are cultivators that command magical beasts on the battlefield."

"No, I have never thought about becoming a Beast Tamer." Yuan shook his head.

"Perhaps you might start thinking about it after today. Follow me, I will show you the magical beasts that we have in stock."

Yuan knew that the middle-aged man was trying to get him to buy a magical beast, but he didn't care and followed the man, as he was truly intrigued in the types of magical beasts that were being sold.

After following the man to the counter, Yuan watched as the man retrieved four books and placed them before him.

"We have four main categories for our magical beasts. Power, agility, flight, and special. Those in the power category are magical beasts with naturally high strength, but they come with slower speed most of the time."

"Magical beasts in the agility category are the opposite with lower strength but higher speed."

"The flight category should be self-explanatory. They're all magical beasts that can fly."

"As for the special category, they're mostly rare magical beasts that are hard to acquire. Which category would you like to see first?"

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Chapter 829 - Nature Of Magical Beasts

Chapter 829 - Nature Of Magical Beasts

"Uhh... The especial category, I guess?" Yuan responded after pondering for a few moments.

"very well".

The man pushed the other three books to the side before placing the especial category in front of Yuan.

"Here you go, buddy. Take your time."

Yuan opened the book and began flipping through the pages, and he could see names of magical beasts and painted pictures of them on each page.

He didn't recognize any of these magical beasts, mostly because he hasn't really encountered any magical beasts since he arrived in Spirit Heaven.

However, judging by their appearance and description, most of these magical beasts appeared to be quite powerful.

"By the way, I should let you know in advance that these magical beasts are all matured. If you wish to look for immature magical beasts, you'll have to visit our action house."

Yuan raised his eyebrows and asked, "Why does it matter if they're mature or not?"

The man chuckled and said, "It matters a lot. Mature magical beasts are more difficult to control and train while immature magical beasts will give you a much easier time. Also, if you properly nurture an immature magical beasts until their maturity, they will be much more powerful than a magical beasts that raised itself in the wild. This is why most people prefer immature magical beasts."

A few minutes later, Yuan closed the book and shook his head, "Sorry, but I am not interested in these magical beasts;"

"Don't worry, we have a lot more magical beasts in the other categories. In fact, the special category has the least choices due to their rarity. Also, just because they are rare doesn't make them more powerful. There are magical beasts in the other categories that are extremely powerful."

"Thank you for the offer, but I don't think my decision will change even if I look at the other categories." Yuan shook his head.

"I see..."

The man took back the books before putting them away.

"Anyways, if you ever change your mind, you know where to find us. We have new magical beasts almost every week. If you're looking for immature magical beasts, you should give our action house a visit. It's only a couple of streets away.

"Okay." Yuan nodded.

He left the place shortly after and began wandering the city again.

"Yingying, I must ask, how do you feel about cultivators capturing magical beasts and selling them?" Yuan suddenly asked her.

He was worried that she might be feeling disgusted by such a business. After all, she is technically a magical beast as well, and it would be akin to watching her own people being sold.

"You don't have to worry about me, I don't feel anything about it." Lan Yingying responded in a calm voice.

"Even though we are all technically magical beasts, we do not see each other like humans see other humans."

"For humans, regardless of your background, you are still considered as humans, and you are able to feel empathy towards other humans, but that is not the case for us magical beasts, as we see other races as a different species."

"In fact, we do not feel intimacy even towards our own race."

"The most important thing to magical beasts are their connections with one another, just like my connection with you."

"I wouldn't feel anything if a stranger died before my eyes, but I would feel pain if I saw you hurt. That's just how all magical beasts function, and that is precisely why we don't care if cultivators capture or hunt other magical beasts."

"In fact, magical beasts also hunt other magical beasts for their cultivation, so we have no right to judge humans for their actions."

"I see..."

Although Yuan was relieved that Lan Yingying wasn't affected by the magical beasts store, he also didn't know that to think about how magical beasts treat each other.

Sometime later, Yuan stopped before a store that sold treasures.

"I don't really need any treasures, but the others would find them useful... However, I don't know that kind of treasures to get for them..."

Yuan pondered about what kind of treasures he could get for Wang Ming and the others.

eventually, he decided to just give them the resources to buy the treasures themselves.

About two hours later, Feng Yuxiang returned to his side.

"I apologize for keeping you waiting, Young Master." She said to him the moment she got back.

"You don't need to apologize for everything, Feng Feng." Yuan said with a smile.

"How was it? Was she satisfied?" He then asked

"I think so." She nodded.

"That's good"

"What should we do now, Young Master? Shall we start making our way towards the demon's valley?"

"Not yet. I need to meet with my companions back at the hotel first, then we'll make our way to the demons'Valley."

"I understand"

Thus, they started their journey back to the original city.

That night, Yuan said to the others, "I have some things to give you all. Meet me at the square tonight. It won't take long."

After dinner, everybody returned to their room and logged into Cultivation Online.

They all gathered at the square and waited for Yuan to arrive.

"I will be busy for a while, so I want to give you these before I leave." Yuan handed each of them a storage pouch

"Can we open it now?" Wang Ming asked

"Go ahead." Yuan nodded

They all opened the storage pouch to find 10,000 spirit stones inside.

"10,000 spirit stones?! That's worth 100 million gold coins" Are you sure you want to give this much money to us?" Shi Lang was shocked.

"It's really not that much, but it should be more than enough to assist you and your cultivation until you reach Spirit Master."

"Also, I plan on ascending to the next realm soon." He suddenly said.

"What? Already? it hasn't even been that long since you came here." Wang Ming asked.

"I'm almost a Spirit King, my cultivation will improve very slowly if I remain in this realm, hence my decision."

"I see..."

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Chapter 830 - Upcoming Disciple Examination

Chapter 830 - Upcoming Disciple Examination

"Yuan, do you need me to come with you?" Chu liuxiang asked him shortly after he handed them spirit stones.

"It's going to be a dangerous journey, and I don't know that to expect, so it would be for the best if I went alone." Yuan shook his head.

"Dangerous? How dangerous?" Li jinxi asked, her eyes filled with curiosity.

"It's a place called demons' Valley, and according to the person who gave me this information, it can make people go crazy if they go there."

"That doesn't sound good... at all." Meixiu said with a worried frown on her face.

"I will be fine." Yuan showed her a confident smile.

After talking with the others for a couple more minutes, Yuan left the square and began making his way towards the Demons' Valley.

A few hours later, near sunrise, Feng Yuxiang said, "Young Master, this is the furthest we can go using the teleportation device. We'll have to travel by ourselves now."

"Will we make it before the examination begins?" He asked

"We should barely make it if we don't stop." Feng Yuxiang nodded

"That's good enough."

They began flying towards their destination after leaving the city.

During their journey, Yuan would spend most of his time staring at the scenery that was mostly filled with mountains and vast empty lands.

At time, he would fly over small villages that only had a dozen houses at most.

Eventually, he realized something.

"Feng Feng, is it just me or is there a lack of water in this world?" Yuan asked her

"A lack of water?" Feng Yuxiang started laughing after hearing his words.

"Young Master, the cultivation world is mostly made up of water. While it may seem like there is a lot of land, the truth is that compared to water, the Nine Heavens is only 30 percent land."

"The Spirit Heaven is mostly land, but once you reach the upper heavens, most cities are separated by many seas, and it would require days if not weeks of traveling just to reach the next city if you do not have a good flying treasure."

"Speaking of flying treasures, where do I buy them? I don't personally need them, but I am thinking about giving them to my friends so that they can travel around more conveniently."

"Flying treasures are quite rare even in this world, and even if you find one, they're not that fast. You'll have to travel to the upper heavens if you want a good flying treasure, but if you still want some, i know of a place in this world that sells them."

"However, your schedule is a little tight right now..."

Yuan then said, "It can wait until I finish my current appointments."

A few hours later, Yuan descended and said, "let's take a break. I will be back in two to three hours."

"Okay"

Feng Yuxiang entered his body to rest, and Yuan logged off shortly after to have breakfast with the others.

"Guys, have you heard about the upcoming disciple examination? Apparently, some big sects are hosting this disciple examination about a week from now, and there are tens of thousands of players that will be participating." Wang Ming suddenly brought up the Seven Spirit Academies' Disciple examination.

"Are you going to participate?" Shi Lang asked him

"I am thinking about it, but since Yuan will be ascending soon, that means we'll get to ascend as well, right? What's the point of joining a sect when I can join a much better sect in the next realm?" Wang Ming said.

Wang Bingbing raised her eyebrows and said, "Have you already forgotten about what happened recently? There are tens of thousands of players currently stuck in Spirit Heaven because they rushed to ascend without having sufficient strength, so they are forced to rely on stronger players to even leave the city."

"The next realm will surely be much harder than Spirit Heaven, and I doubt anyone but Yuan would be able to survive such a place."

"Now that you mention it..." Wang Ming began reconsidering his decision.

"What do you think, Yuan? Should we join one of these sects?" Hong Xiuquan suddenly asked him.

Yuan pondered for a moment before nodding his head, "Honestly, I think it would benefit all of you if you joined a sect. Wang Bingbing is right. Even if I ascend to the next realm, I don't think you should follow me, especially since we don't know what's up there."

"Furthermore, the sects in question are top sects in Spirit Heaven, and there are seven of them. I'm sure there's a lot of new things you can learn from them."

The others exchanged glances with each other.

"So who's going to participate?" Wang Ming asked them

"I'll do it." Shi Lang said.

"We cannot rely on Yuan for everything. I am going to join a sect and improve myself from there."

Wu Zao nodded and said, "I will also participate. I don't have anything else to do, anyway."

One by one, the Demon Sealing Faction decided to join a sect.

"What about you, Li Jinxi?" They turned to look at her.

"I'm fine by myself." She calmly responded

"Really? How do you even train yourself nowadays?" Xi Murong asked her.

"I hunt monsters." She quickly replied

"That's it?"

Li Jinxi nodded

"As expected from the tyrannical gorilla... She probably enjoys hunting monsters all day..." Wang Ming mumbled in a low voice.

"I heard you." Li Jinxi narrowed her eyes at him, causing him to tremble.

"I-It's just a joke."

"Anyways, I do not intend on joining any sects. I am satisfied with my current routine, and I get a lot of monster cores from it as well," She said a

moment later.

"If that's what you want to do, we won't try to convince you." Shi Lang said.

"The two of you will probably follow Yuan when he ascends, right?" Wang Bingbing suddenly turned to look at Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang.

"Of course." Chu Liuxiang immediately responded.

Meixiu also agreed by nodding her head.

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Chapter 831 - Have You Seen My Son?

Chapter 831 - Have You Seen My Son?

After talking with the others for a couple more minutes, everyone returned to their own schedule, which consisted of mostly morning practice, so everyone except Yuan went to the training field.

As for Yuan, he returned to Cultivation Online so that he could continue making his journey to the Demons' Valley.

Many hours later, Yuan could suddenly sense a chilly sensation on his skin, causing him to tremble slightly. However, it wasn't because of the weather, and a cultivator of his level wouldn't be affected by normal cold weather.

"What is this feeling? It's unpleasant." Yuan asked Feng Yuxiang, who didn't seem affected at all.

"It must be the Demons' Valley miasma," she said.

"You don't feel it?" Yuan asked her with a raised eyebrow.

"No, it appears that the miasma doesn't affect Divine Beasts. However, this is truly unexpected. I didn't expect for the miasma to reach all the way here since we're still a few hours away from the town. It wasn't this bad the last time I was here.

"You came to the Demons' Valley before?"

"Somewhat. I flew over it, but I never went inside, and that was thousands of years ago."

"I see. How was the place when you flew over it?"

"It was desolate and had this grim atmosphere. That's all I can remember."

"Why is the place like this?" Yuan continued to ask.

"Who knows. According to my knowledge, demons used to roam that land very frequently and even made it into some sort of stronghold, hence its name. However, after the Demon Clan was defeated by humans, they all seemingly disappeared, leaving behind this miasma that makes people crazy if they stay

"Demons, huh? Honestly, I wanted to visit the Demons' Valley not entirely because of Jia Chong. I was intrigued by this place's name, so I wanted to see what it was like for myself." Yuan suddenly said.

"Do you think it's because of your memories as the Divine Paragon that made you interested in Demons' Valley?" Feng Yuxiang then asked.

"Who knows, but it feels like I am always encountering demons, almost like we're fated to cross paths everywhere I go." Yuan sighed.

A few hours later, Feng Yuxiang said, "We're almost there, Young Master. Are you okay with the miasma? Do you feel unwell?"

Yuan shook his head, "I am fine. The miasma is unpleasant and makes my skin crawl, but I don't feel any differently than normal."

"That's good to hear. But since we're going to the town first, I should talk a little about it."

"First of all, the town is a nameless place. It probably had a name before, but it was forgotten with time. I personally have never been to the town before, but I asked the Moonlight Brokers about it before I left, and Yue Yin told me that it's a town filled with crazy people, warning me that we shouldn't interact with them.

"According to her, many people go missing in that place, and its residents act like they're possessed by something. Due to its bad reputation, it rarely

receives any guests. The only people that go to that place are cultivators who are interested in the Demons' Valley. There are rumors of hidden treasures within the Demons' Valley, so it's a hot spot for treasure hunters."

"Sounds like a complicated place."

About an hour later, they arrived at the nameless town.

About an hour later, they arrived at the nameless town. "The miasma inside this town is way stronger than anything I have felt outside." Yuan muttered in a low voice as he entered the town that didn't even have any guards.

At first glance, the place looked very empty, almost as though it was a ghost town. However, he quickly realized that was not the case.

"Young Master, they're watching us from their houses." Feng Yuxiang suddenly said to him.

He nodded, "Yes, I can see them with my divine sense. There is definitely something off about them."

After walking around the town for about half an hour without seeing a single individual, Yuan sighed, "How are we supposed to find the Myriad of Techniques if there's nobody to guide us there?"

"This is a relatively small town, so we'll probably find it just by walking around." Feng Yuxiang said.

After a few more minutes of wandering, Yuan finally found someone in the street- a very skinny old woman standing in the street with a dazed look on her pale face.

Yuan swallowed nervously when he saw this old woman that looked almost like a skeleton. Although he has never watched any horror movies before, Yu Rou used to tell him scary stories on special occasions, and in all of her stories, there would always be a creepy-looking old woman.

Yuan's instincts told him to not approach this old woman, but he wanted to find the Myriad of Techniques as soon as possible or he would be late for

the examination.

'Calm down. There's nothing this old woman can do to harm you.' Yuan told this to himself as he approached the old woman at a slow but steady pace.

"H-Hello. Do you know where I can find the Myriad of Techniques?" Yuan asked in a nervous but clear voice.

However, the old woman acted as though she didn't even hear him, and she continued to stare at the space in front of her with a blank expression.

Figuring that she didn't hear him, Yuan decided to ask her again in a louder voice, "Do you know where I can find the Myriad of Techniques?"

This time, the old woman turned to look at him with stiff movement.

"Have you seen my son?" She asked him in a hoarse voice.

"Uh." Yuan was taken aback by the old woman's response.

"No, I haven't." He eventually responded.

The old woman then continued, "Do you know where my son is? He should have returned to me by now..."

"Sorry, but I don't know where your son is." Yuan shook his head.

After a moment of silence, the old woman suddenly started screaming, "YOU! YOU TOOK MY SON, DIDN'T YOU?! GIVE MY SON BACK!"

It was at this moment the old woman revealed her hands that had been hiding underneath her clothes, and it was clutching onto a kitchen knife.

"DIE!"

The old woman brandished the kitchen knife at Yuan without any hesitation...

Chapter 832 - Nameless Town

Chapter 832 - Nameless Town

Yuan's eyes widened when he saw the old woman brandishing her kitchen knife at him out of the blue.

However, before he could even react, Feng Yuxiang, who had been prepared to act at a moment's notice, waved her hand and released a blast of spiritual energy at the aggressor, sending the old woman flying to the next street.

Yuan stared at the old woman that had fallen a street away with a baffled look on his face, and he turned to look at Feng Yuxiang.

"Feng Feng, did you really have to do that? That woman wasn't a cultivator, so there was no way that kitchen knife could've hurt me."

"Mortal or not, she dared to attack Young Master, so she will be punished." Feng Yuxiang said with a firm look on her face.

"I hope you didn't kill her.." Yuan sighed.

However, when he turned back to look at the street, he could not see the old woman anywhere.

"Huh? Where did she go?" Yuan looked around, but he couldn't see even a shadow.

"She probably got scared and ran away. I didn't even use that much strength just now, so she should be fine." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Since there's nobody we can ask for help, I guess we can only continue to look for the Myriad of Techniques by ourselves."

Eventually, Yuan gave up on walking on foot and started flying around the town.

After about fifteen minutes of circling around the desolate town, they finally found the Myriad of Techniques, which was hidden in a narrow space between two ordinary-looking buildings.

If it were not for the fact that he'd seen the same entrance multiple times by now, Yuan would've definitely missed it.

Upon entering the Myriad of Techniques, they were greeted by the usual scenery that was filled with warmth and light, the polar opposite of the nameless town.

The tingly sensation on his skin immediately disappeared the moment Yuan entered the Myriad of Techniques, allowing him to finally breathe normally.

Sometime later, he made his way to the Demon Sealing Clan's Grand Library.

After coming out of the portal in the Grand Library, Yuan approached the building in the distance, but it was completely empty there due to the drama between the Demon Sealing Clan and the Demon Sealing Grotto.

"You're the little founder.. What are you doing here? Didn't you hear? The Grand Library is closed until further notice." The man that gave Yuan the badge when he first arrived was still there to guard the entrance even though it was closed.

"I'm here to take my demon sealing examination with Senior Yan," he explained the situation to him.

"Give me a moment to confirm this." The man retrieved a communication jade slip and contacted Yan Hara, who was somewhere within the Grand Library.

"Are you expecting the little founder?" He asked her.

"Yes, please let him inside." Yan Hara quickly responded.

The man turned to look at Yuan and silently nodded.

"Thank you." Yuan bowed to the man before making his way inside the Grand Library.

Once inside, he walked straight to the area with the Divine Paragon's statue.

When he arrived, he could see five people standing in front of the statue.

Yuan immediately recognized three of these people.

They were Yan Hara, Tang Zheng, and surprisingly, Wan Yu.

As for the last two individuals, they were a beautiful young lady and a handsome young man that Yuan did not recognize at all.

The young lady was wearing the Demon Sealing Clan's uniform while the young man wore the Demon Sealing Grotto's uniform.

"You're late, little founder." Yan Hara said to him in a relaxed tone when she noticed his presence.

"Sorry, but something came up and I had to travel to another location." Yuan said with an apologetic smile.

"So that's the rumored 'little founder', huh. I must say, he really resembles the Divine Paragon, but his cultivation is too weak. Are you sure he should be participating in the examination?" The handsome young man showed a provocative smile after seeing Yuan.

The young lady merely glared at Yuan with a deep gaze, her thoughts unknown.

Yuan glanced at the handsome young man before ignoring him.

He looked around the place, showing a puzzled expression on his face when he couldn't see any artificial demons in the area.

"Are you looking for the artificial demons?" Tang Zhang read his thoughts and asked with a smile.

Yuan nodded.

"Hahaha! Don't tell me that you're participating in this examination without even knowing anything about it?! I have never met anyone like you before!" The young man started laughing when he realized the situation.

"Calm down, Wan Kaiqi." Wan Yu narrowed his eyes on the handsome young man.

"Sorry, Uncle Wan, but this guy is too much for me." The young man, who turned out to be Wan Yu's nephew, spoke as he wiped his tears.

"It's my fault. I forgot to explain the examination to you." Yan Hara suddenly realized this fact and apologized to him.

"It's fine. The details don't really matter to me. I intend on passing the examination no matter what, after all." Yuan said with a confident smile on his face.

"Well spoken." Wan Yu smiled, and he continued, "When I heard that you wanted to become an Elite Demon Sealer, I immediately volunteered to become a judge. I missed it when you became an Advanced Demon Sealer, but I won't miss this one. "

"Anyways, now that everyone is here, let's go to the area where the examination will take place." Tang Zheng said, and he suddenly began creating array symbols the next moment.

A few moments later, Tang Zheng combined the array symbols into a single powerful array before infusing the array with the Divine Paragon's statue beside him.

A few moments later, a red portal appeared before them, and Tang Zheng entered it without hesitation.

The others followed with Yuan entering last.

After exiting from the portal, Yuan was greeted by the scenery of a mountain valley, but there was something ominous about it, and the sensation he felt from the nameless town could suddenly be felt again, but it was much more intensive this time...

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Chapter 833 - Elite Demon Sealer's Examination

Chapter 833 - Elite Demon Sealer's Examination

"This feeling... It's almost as though I have returned to the nameless town with that crazy old lady..." Yuan thought to himself as he stared at the mountain valley.

"In order to pass the examination and become an Elite Demon Sealer, you must traverse this Demons' Valley and reach the end within 3 days." Yan Hara said to them sometime later.

"Demons' Valley?" Yuan immediately raised his eyebrows upon hearing this familiar name, wondering if this is some kind of freaky coincidence or fate.

"Yes, this place used to be inhabited by mostly low-ranking demons in the lower heavens. Of course, this isn't the real location. It's just a recreation of the place." Yan Hara said.

And she continued, "The real Demons' Valley is much larger than this place since this is just a portion of the real thing. It's about 100 miles from here to the end, but you're not allowed to fly during the examination, and you'll encounter demons on your way there."

Tang Zheng then spoke, "You can ignore the demons and finish the examination without sealing a single demon, but you acquire points for sealing demons- bonus points if you can kill them. At the end, depending on your points, you'll be able to receive a demon sealing treasure from the treasury."

Wan Yu spoke next, "Demon sealing treasures are very rare, so I recommend that you try to acquire as many points as you can during this examination."

Yan Hara approached Yuan and handed him a necklace.

"Wear this so we know your location at all times. The demons may not be real, but they can still inflict real injuries, so you should treat them as though you're fighting a real demon."

Yuan accepted the necklace and wore it around his neck.

He then watched as Yan Hara handed Wu Kaiqi and the young lady the same necklace.

'They're also participating in this examination?' Yuan thought they were there as judges at first, but that didn't seem to be the case.

"Now onto the rules for the examination." Yan Hara spoke, and she continued, "As I'd already mentioned, you are not allowed to fly in the examination. You are allowed to use any treasures during the examination, but demon sealing treasures are forbidden."

"You have 72 hours to traverse the Demons' Valley and reach the end. You will know it's the end when you see the Divine Paragon's statue. If you are lost, you can look at the sky and follow that red star."

Yuan followed Yan Hara's finger that was pointed at the sky, and sure enough, there was a bright crimson star flickering in the yellow sky.

"You may forfeit the examination at any time by destroying the crystal on your necklace, but if you fail the examination, you will not be able to partake in it for another 10 years."

'Ten years?!' Yuan cried inwardly.

Although ten years may seem like nothing for these powerful cultivators that have lived for hundreds if not thousands of years, it was a significant amount of time for Yuan, who has only lived for 18 years.

'I cannot fail this examination no matter what.' Yuan told himself as Yan Hara continued to speak.

"As mentioned already, you are not required to fight any demons you encounter during the examination, but you will receive points for doing so. You will receive 1 point for sealing any Lower Demons, 5 points for sealing Elite Demons, 10 points for Superior Demons, which will be the highest ranking demon available during the examination, and if you manage to kill the demon, you will receive double points ."

"At the end of the examination, you may use your points to trade for demon sealing treasures. And before you ask- yes, you are allowed to trade for multiple demon sealing treasures as long as you have enough points, so good luck with that ."

"Do you have any questions before we start this examination?"

Yuan raised his hands and asked, "How do we know how much time we have left?"

"We will let you know through the necklace every 24 hours for the first two days. On the final day, we will remind you every 4 hours, and during the last four hours, we will remind you every hour." Tang Zheng responded.

"I understand." Yuan nodded.

"Do you two have any questions?" Wan Yu asked the other two participants.

They shook their heads.

"Then we will begin the examination now. We will begin the timer once you enter the Demons' Valley. Good luck." Yan Hara said to them before the judges flew away, disappearing from their sights.

Once they were alone, Wan Kaiqi turned to look at the young lady and said, "Daoist Huan, let's have a friendly competition to see who receives the most points during the examination. If you win, I will give you all of my points, but if I win, you will go on a date with me."

The young lady surnamed Huan turned to look at Wu Kaiqi and spoke in a nonchalant voice, "I don't like your smile."

And without explaining any further, she turned around and disappeared into the Demons' Valley.

Wan Kaiqi turned to look at Yuan, who had been staring at them, and scoffed, "What are you looking at? A Spirit Lord like you won't survive even a day inside the Demons' Valley."

"Do you want to gamble on that claim? If you win, I will give you all of my points, but if I win, you will give me your points." Yuan suddenly responded in a way that Wan Kaiqi didn't expect.

Wan Kaiqi coldly snorted after snapping out of his daze, "That's not fair at all. You can simply go into hiding for an entire day."

Yuan then said, "Okay, let's use your rules instead. Whoever acquires the most points during the examination will take the loser's points."

"That's more like it." A confident smile appeared on Wan Kaiqi's face.

"So you agree?" Yuan asked for confirmation.

"Yes." Wan Kaiqi nodded.

"Good. Then may the best one win." Yuan clasped his hands and bowed to Wan Kaiqi before entering the Demons' Valley.

"Arrogant brat, you won't be acting so smug in three days!" Wan Kaiqi also entered the Demons' Valley shortly after..

Chapter 834 - Demons' Valley

Chapter 834 - Demons' Valley

After entering the Demons' Valley, Yuan's vision blurred for a second, and when it cleared up, he found himself in a different area.

He had been teleported somewhere, but he still appeared to be within the Demons' Valley.

He turned around and waited to see if Wan Kaiqi would show up, but when nobody showed up after a minute, he figured that Wan Kaiqi had also been teleported somewhere.

'They probably did this to separate us.' Yuan thought.

He tilted his head until he was staring at the sky, and when he located the red star in the sky, he started walking towards that direction.

'We have three days to complete this examination, which is a lot of time even if we cannot fly. This is probably on purpose to encourage us to fight demons and earn points.'

'Not only do I have to beat Wan Kaiqi, but this is also good practice for me. Hopefully, there are enough demons in this place to satisfy me.'

Yuan decided to focus on hunting demons instead of just rushing to the finish line.

Of course, the other two participants also had the same thoughts.

They all believed that they would be able to reach the goal with ease and with plenty of time to spare, so they might as well use that spare time to

hunt for points and acquire a demon sealing treasure or two.

Meanwhile, in another location, Yan Hara and the other two judges watched the participants through a mirror.

"I know he's a talented young man, but don't you think it's a little too much to allow him to participate in this examination? After all, these demons don't scale to his strength, so they will all have a higher cultivation than him." Tang Zheng asked Yan Hara.

After a moment of silence, she responded in a calm voice, "I want to see his limit. He might be lacking in terms of cultivation compared to the other two, but his demon sealing aura is by no means inferior. In fact, he might even surpass them."

"Also, he's going to be the future leader of the Demon Sealing Clan. He'll need some achievements under his belt before then."

"You seem very confident in his abilities. However, if you ask me, he's still far behind the current leader of the Demon Sealing Clan." Wan Yu suddenly said.

And he continued, "Oh, I don't mean his talents. His talents are definitely terrifying, and he has the potential to surpass even the current leader. However, he will need more than talent to become the leader of the Demon Sealing Clan. His character is too soft and naive at this moment."

"You cannot expect a baby to suddenly start cultivating. He's still young and inexperienced, but he will eventually grow up-I will make sure of it." Yan Hara said.

Wan Yu sighed, "If he survives, that is. What a pity that he's with the Demon Sealing Clan."

"What's that supposed to mean?" Yan Hara frowned.

Wan Yu shrugged and said, "The strife between the two clans is getting worse by the day. I'll be surprised if there's a Demon Sealing Clan by the

time he 'grows up'."

"What? That's bullshit!" Yan Hara immediately exclaimed.

"Bullshit? You know, this isn't the first time our people have died by Qian Chu's hands. In fact, ever since he became the leader of the Demon Sealing Clan, our Demon Sealing Grotto have encountered many misfortunate situations where our top demon sealers are being killed in 'accidents' that involved Qian Chu one way or another. However, this is the first time we have lost 3 Master Demon Sealers in one day, and they all died in an event managed by Qian Chu."

"Even though Qian Chu denies all accusations, we all know that's just plain bullshit."

"What happened during the tournament was just an accident! In case you forgot, I was also part of it, and I nearly died if not for the Leader! Why would the Leader risk losing two Master Demon Sealers just to harm the Demon Sealing Grotto ? That doesn't make any sense!" Yan Hara said.

"Hmph! Then let me ask you this. Why did the Leader save you but allowed the others to die? Why did everyone from the Demon Sealing Grotto die while the Demon Sealing Clan received zero casualties? A coincidence? I don't f#cking think so!"

"Are you accusing me of being part of this conspiracy now?! I can't believe you!" Yan Hara exclaimed in an angry voice.

"I'm not accusing you of anything. In fact, I wholeheartedly believe that Qian Chu would be willing to sacrifice his own people just to achieve his goals. He's just that kind of person."

"You know, during interrogation, when the Demon Sealing Grotto asked Qian Chu why he only saved you, he claimed that he did not do such a thing and that someone else had saved you by taking control of his Demon Sealing Flag! Who the hell would believe that?! Besides the Divine Paragon, nobody in the Nine Heavens has the ability to hijack the Demon Sealing Flag right under Qian Chu's nose!"

"What.?" Yan Hara became speechless after hearing this information from Wan Yu.

Qian Chu didn't save her? Then who saved her?

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Chapter 835 - Demons' Valley(2)

Chapter 835: Demons' Valley(2)

"Anyways, that's all I have to say on the matter. The higher ups will handle everything." Wan Yu said before focusing on the participants again.

Yan Hara and Tang Zheng looked at each other with perplexed expressions. Did Qian Chu really intentionally let the participants die? Was he really willing to sacrifice his own people to achieve his own goals? It was hard to swallow such a thought, especially since Qian Chu is admired by many people.

Meanwhile, inside the Demons' Valley, Yuan encountered his first demon when it suddenly showed up out of the blue and attacked him.

"F-Feng Feng... What cultivation is that demon? I cannot sense it, so it must be fairly high..." Yuan asked her after realizing this fact.

"It has a cultivation of peak Spirit Emperor." Feng Yuxiang immediately responded.

Yuan swallowed nervously after hearing this information.

Peak Spirit Emperor? That is an entire realm above Spirit King and almost a Spirit Sovereign! How on earth is he supposed to fight such a monster as a Spirit Lord?

'I have underestimated this examination...' Yuan sighed inwardly.

He knew it was going to be harder than the last examination, but he didn't expect such a massive jump in difficulty.

The last examination was so easy that it was basically free, so Yuan didn't think this examination would be so difficult even if they increased the difficulty several levels.

'Calm down... They may have a much higher cultivation than I'd anticipated, but they are still vulnerable to demon sealing aura. If my demon sealing aura is strong enough, I should be able to seal it...' Yuan tried to calm himself.

While he was doing that, the demon snickered, "How dare a mere Spirit Lord step foot inside the Demons' Valley? Courting death!"

"Young Master, do you need my help?" Feng Yuxiang asked him. "

No, I can handle this, and I'm not sure you're allowed to help me." He shook his head.

"I understand. Please be careful, Young Master."

Yuan nodded and summoned the Empyrean Overlord.

"You're a bold one, human. I will give you that." The demon showed an ugly smile on its face.

"You talk too much. You may have a higher cultivation, but you're just a low-ranking demon." Yuan suddenly said.

The demon was immediately enraged after hearing Yuan's provoking words. As a low-ranking demon, they have almost zero control over their emotions, especially anger, so they can be triggered easily.

"Die!" The demon pounced at Yuan the next moment.

Yuan did not retreat and confronted the demon head-on instead.

[Demon Sealing Strike!]

The Empyrean Overlord gushed with demon sealing aura as it slashed at the surprised demon.

The demon was unable to react due to being surprised by the overwhelming amount of demon sealing aura released by Yuan, and it did not expect a Spirit Lord to be capable of releasing such a strong aura.

Sha!

The Empyrean Overlord sliced the demon in half.

However, the demon did not immediately become sealed and quickly regenerated a moment later.

"N-Not bad. I underestimated you, human." The smile on the demon's face trembled slightly. It was obviously afraid of Yuan's demon sealing aura despite their cultivation differences.

Although the demon had an advantage in cultivation, such an advantage could be negated if its opponent's demon sealing aura was strong enough.

This is why demon sealers in ancient times took priority in their demon sealing aura over their cultivation.

In this case, Yuan's demon sealing aura was strong enough to threaten the demon with a Spirit Emperor cultivation base, and if it were not for the demon's superior cultivation, it would have been sealed in a single strike. Seeing the demon's reaction to his demon sealing aura, Yuan's confidence increased tremendously, so he went for another strike.

[Demon Sealing Strike!]

This time, the demon did not dare to take his attack head-on and opted to dodge it instead.

However, Yuan was relentless with his attacks and eventually landed another strike on the demon.

The demon's movements became noticeably slower and stiffer after the second strike, and when Yuan noticed this, he increased the intensity of his attacks, not stopping until the demon was fully sealed.

Once the demon was fully sealed, Yuan decided to kill it for the extra points.

After taking all the time he needed to fully charge his attack, Yuan released a devastating attack named Heavenly Splitting Sword Strike, completely erasing the demon and the terrain behind it almost instantly.

The destroyed terrain would return like nothing had happened after a couple of moments, but the demon never recovered.

The entire Demons' Valley seemingly shook for a brief second after the attack, causing the other two participants to look around with caution.

Meanwhile, the judges that had been spectating Yuan's first encounter were left speechless by what they had just witnessed.

"What kind of attack is that? He erased an entire mountain in a split second!" Yan Hara exclaimed in a shocked voice.

"His demon sealing aura increased so much in such a short time..." Wan Yu mumbled in a low voice filled with disbelief, his focus elsewhere.

"Unbelievable. I truly did not expect him to deal with the demon so effortlessly... It appears that my worries were unnecessary." Tang Zheng sighed.

Although the three of them were aware of Yuan's talent, they had no idea of his full potential, so it was quite shocking to see it for the first time.

After killing the demon, Yuan released a relieved sigh, "That went better than I anticipated. Looks like I don't need to be so worried about this examination, after all."

However, he was not completely stress-free just yet. Although he'd killed the demon, it was only a low-ranking demon, and he wasn't confident that he would be able to achieve the same results fighting an Elite or Superior Demon.

After spending a few minutes recovering his spiritual energy, Yuan continued to look for more demons to kill, and after wandering for a couple of minutes, another demon would show up out of nowhere to attack him.

Once again, it was a low-ranking demon with a peak Spirit Emperor cultivation, but Yuan didn't hesitate to attack it this time, quickly sealing it in just a few minutes..

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Chapter 836: Sublime Scriptures of Heaven

Chapter 836: Sublime Scriptures of Heaven

'It's really unfortunate that these demons don't drop demon cores...' Yuan sighed inwardly after killing his second demon in the examination.

Sometime later, Yuan stopped walking when he noticed a statue in the distance.

When he approached it, he realized that it was actually a demon that had already been sealed.

'Did one of the other two participants seal this demon?' He wondered to himself.

Regardless if it was sealed by someone else or not, Yuan did not intend on leaving behind free points and decided to erase the demon completely, taking the points for himself.

After releasing the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike, Yuan took a few minutes to recover his strength before making his move again.

'I hope I get points for finishing off someone else's demon, even if I don't receive the full credit...'

Meanwhile, Wan Yu laughed out loud after witnessing Yuan's actions.

"This is the first time that I have witnessed someone killing another person's sealed demon." He laughed out loud.

"Well, this is my first time seeing a Spirit Lord killing demons two realms above their own level." Tang Zheng said.

"Just what kind of technique is he using? I don't recognize it at all." Yan Hara mumbled in a pondering voice.

Wan Yu then said, "It resembles an ancient technique from a legend I heard before, but I doubt it's actually the same technique."

"Legend?" The other two looked at him with raised eyebrows.

"Yes, it's called the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike, and it's only part of another technique called the Heaven's Secret Art."

"Have you heard of the Sublime Scriptures of Heaven?" He asked them.

Tang Zheng nodded and spoke, "I have heard about them before. Legend has it that the mighty Heaven itself created these techniques alongside the cultivation world during its creation, and they are the most powerful cultivation techniques to ever exist. There are four different techniques with Heaven's Secret Art being one of them."

"Rumor also has it that they were gifted to the four most powerful families that served the first Celestial Emperor, but nobody has seen these techniques since ancient times, so people question if they even really exist."

"That's right, and the Heaven Splitting Sword Art is part of Heaven's Secret Art." Wan Yu nodded.

And he continued, "However, you are not entirely correct."

"Huh? What did I get wrong?" Tang Zheng asked.

"The Sublime Scriptures of Heaven truly exist and people have seen them before. In fact, the people that own these techniques currently reside in the Supreme Heaven."

"However, that is only the case for three of these four techniques. The fourth technique, Heaven's Secret Art, is said to be owned by the legendary

Asura Clan, but since they have been exiled for countless years now, nobody can confirm that information, hence why the technique is a legend."

"The Asura Clan, huh. I heard a lot about them, but I never understood why they were exiled— I mean, I know the reason they were exiled, but I don't understand why they did what exiled them." Yan Hara sighed.

And she continued, "However, what puzzles me the most is how they refuse to participate in Supreme Heaven's Legacy for their freedom."

"They must have their own reasons." Wan Yu shrugged.

It was at this moment Yan Hara had a sudden realization.

'Huh? Wait a minute... The Supreme Heaven's Legacy?'

After pondering for a moment, Yan Hara turned to look at Wan Yu and asked, "The Asura Clan... What is their surname?"

"Give me a second..." Wan Yu closed his eyes to think.

A moment later, he opened his eyes and said, "If my memories serve me correctly, the Asura Clan should have the surname 'Xiao'."

Yan Hara swallowed nervously after hearing this information.

'Xiao... Xiao Hua... It can't be... But there's no way it's just a coincidence. Why would the Asura Clan suddenly decide to participate in the Supreme Heaven's Legacy when they've avoided it for countless years?'

Either this is all just a freaky coincidence or there is something bigger at play here.

A few hours later, Wan Yu looked at the scoreboard and smiled, "Yuan is currently leading with 30 points while the other two are almost neck to neck with 22 points and 21 points. Despite his advantage, the little founder isn't as efficient in locating demons as the other two, so he's not too far ahead. If he couldn't kill demons with his ridiculous technique, he would be last place right now."

"He's also only ran into low-ranking demons while the other two have already encountered an Elite Demon." Tang Zheng added.

"It will only be a matter of time until he encounters an Elite or Superior Demon..." Yan Hara mumbled in a slightly nervous tone, as she wasn't confident that he could really deal with them at his current level.

However, the very next moment, Yuan would encounter his first Elite Demon.

"Speaking of the devil..." A smile filled with intrigue appeared on Wan Yu's face as he focused on Yuan's situation.

"Young Master, this demon is different from the rest. You should be careful." Feng Yuxiang warned him when she sensed that something was off about this demon.

"It's an Elite Demon." Yuan immediately recognized its rank since he had fought one before.

When the Elite Demon noticed Yuan, it didn't immediately attack him and actually took a moment to take a deep breath.

"Aaaah... Human, I can smell a chaotic energy hidden deep within you. Although the energy is almost nonexistent right now, it will eventually bloom into something magnificent, and when it does, I can only imagine the chaos you'll cause to the cultivation world— it would definitely be a sight to behold." The Elite Demon said to him with a calm smile on its face.

"..."

Although Yuan didn't take the demon's words to heart, he had a bad feeling about it, and it made him recall the madness that consumed his mind not long ago at the Qi Family..

Chapter 837: The Abomination

Chapter 837: The Abomination

"Show me what you've got, human."

Perhaps it was because of Yuan's lack of cultivation, but the Elite Demon did not seem to be worried at all by his presence.

"Then I won't be humble!"

Yuan started the assault with the Demon Sealing Sword Strike.

However, the Elite Demon quickly dodged it, not allowing Yuan's strike to connect, unlike the low-ranking demons before it that were so confident in their immortal bodies that they would disregard all attacks.

Seeing this, Yuan summoned the Starry Abyss to sneak attack the Elite Demon.

"Pathetic little tricks!"

The Elite Demon summoned its blood weapon and parried the incoming attack from the back.

'I forgot that the Starry Abyss isn't effective against Spirit Kings and above...' Yuan facepalmed inwardly.

'But this is fine. The invisibility effect isn't the reason I summoned it.'

[Ten Thousand Ghost Blades!]

"If one isn't enough, how about a thousand?!"

A thousand Starry Abyss suddenly appeared and surrounded the Elite Demon.

Although the demon was definitely taken aback by such a menacing technique, it did not panic and tried its best to deflect all of them.

However, such a feat quickly proved to be impossible for the Elite Demon, so it stopped focusing on the Starry Abyss and started launching its own attack at Yuan, who was just standing in the distance, silently controlling the Starry Abyss.

"Blood Slash!"

The Elite Demon whisked its thin arms at Yuan, sending a crimson arc of energy at him.

However, the attack didn't go far, as it was quickly intercepted by the thousand Starry Abyss that acted like a containment for the demon.

"What a fucking annoying technique!"

The Elite Demon could no longer control its emotions and became enraged.

Its frame grew larger, and its chaotic aura surged to a new level.

However, despite its transformation, it could not conquer the Starry Abyss, eventually getting sealed by it.

Yuan sighed in relief afterward.

'I should be more confident in myself.' Yuan told himself after finishing off the sealed demon with the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike, acquiring to more points.

"This fellow is full of surprises. He controls not just a single Soul Weapon but two of them, and they're different types of weapons? I only know of one person that can wield two Soul Weapons at once, and that person is regarded as a top genius in the Seventh Heaven." Wan Yu's face was filled with awe after witnessing Yuan's fight with the Elite Demon.

'Two Soul Weapons... Just how many more secrets are hiding inside that small figure? Van Hara wondered to herself.

After recovering his spiritual energy, Yuan continued his hunt. Many hours later, the necklace given to him before the examination suddenly trembled, and Yan Hara's voice resounded from it.

"It has been 24 hours since the start of the examination. You have 48 hours left."

'It's already been an entire day? Time sure passes by so quickly when I am focused on hunting demons... Luckily I told the others not to worry about me if I don't come out for a few days since I didn't know what to expect from this examination.'

He would normally take a break for Meixiu's meals, but he was worried that he might lose his bet with Wan Kaiqi if he rested even a little, as he was certain that the other two participants would spend every second during the examination hunting for more points.

As Yuan spent more time hunting demons, he grew more confident in his abilities, and his aggressiveness intensified. This allowed him to swiftly deal with even Elite Demons, and his points grew more and more.

'I have encountered four Elite Demons now, but I have yet to encounter any Superior Demons. I wonder if they are closer to the goal.' Yuan wondered inwardly as he finished off another demon.

After pondering for a moment, he decided to see how close he was to the finish line, as he'd been wandering the Demons' Valley aimlessly.

Yuan followed the direction of the red star and ran at his full speed, only stopping to deal with demons that would suddenly show up.

A few hours later, Yuan stopped when he could see the Divine Paragon's statue.

'I encountered three Elite Demons on my way here, which is almost as much as what I encountered after an entire day of roaming. Looks like my hypothesis was correct. I should encounter my first Superior Demon soon if I continue to wander around the statue.'

Not wanting to waste any more time, Yuan began running around the area around the statue, and sure enough, an hour and three dead demons later, he encountered his first Superior Demon.

However, when Yuan saw this demon, he swallowed nervously, and all of the confidence that he'd built up over the course of the last 24 hours began dwindling.

"My lord... This is a demon?" Yuan mumbled in a low voice as his gaze laid on a massive figure that was nearly 40 meters tall in the far distance.

This demon was not only incredibly tall, it was also very round, almost like a balloon. However, that was not the most appalling feature of this demon, as it had an unfathomably hideous face that would scare anyone unfortunate to witness it. 0

The demons before this one all had human-like appearance, but this demon looked more like a hideous monster than anything.

"What an ugly demon! Hurry up and kill it, Young Master!" Feng Yuxiang exclaimed in a disgusted voice the moment she saw this demon.

Even Lan Yingying trembled when she saw this demon, as it was unlike anything she had seen before.

"I-I think we should probably leave this one alone for now..." Yuan said in a stiff voice.

And without any hesitation, he turned around and walked away, acting as though he never even noticed the demon.

"Hahaha! Did you see the look on his face?! I knew he'd run away! Nobody has ever confronted that hideous existence on their first encounter! They

would always need some time to mentally prepare themselves, even if they knew of its existence beforehand!" Wan Yu laughed out loud after seeing Yuan's natural reaction to this massive demon.

"I almost pissed myself when I first encountered it during my examination." Tang Zheng shook his head with a bittersweet smile on his face as he recalled his first encounter with this demon.

"The 'Abomination', huh? I still don't understand their existence and why they look so different from other demons." Van Hara said.

"Some people believe they are the demons' true appearance. However, according to the Demon Sealing Clan from ancient times, even demons hated these Abominations." Wan Yu said.

"I'm just glad that they no longer exist. I cannot imagine going against these things nowadays. They are not only more violent than other demons but they also seem to have no mind of their own, acting merely on their destructive instincts." Tang Zheng shook his head.

"That's not all." Wan Yu said, and he continued, "They also have a higher tolerance to demon sealing aura, so they are much tougher to seal in general."

"Despite it only being a Superior Demon, I don't think anyone has ever sealed or killed the Abomination in this examination. Not even Qian Chu, who fought it for an entire day, could defeat it."

"Perhaps the little founder will set a precedent." Yan Hara said with an anticipating smile on her face...

Chapter 838: Deep Within His Consciousness

Chapter 838: Deep Within His Consciousness

"Y-Yingying! What in heavens' name was that thing?! There's no way that thing is a demon!" Yuan asked her after running away from the hideous-looking demon.

"I have no idea... That was also my first time seeing that kind of demon." She said.

"What about your grandparents? Have they ever mentioned a demon like that before?"

"No."

"What about you, Feng Feng? Do you know anything about that demon?" Yuan continued to ask.

"Sorry, but I have also never heard of such a demon before."

Yuan sighed, "I cannot believe such a monster exists in this world."

After a moment of silence, Lan Yingying asked him, "Are you going to fight it?"

"Uhh..." Yuan hesitated on answering.

Even though he could get a lot of points by killing the hideous demon, he wasn't sure it was worth the trouble, as it gave him a really dreadful feeling.

Suddenly, Van Hara's voice resounded from the necklace, "Little founder, if you can defeat the Abomination, you'll get L000 points."

"The Abomination? Is that what it's called? Just what is that thing? Is it really a demon?" Yuan asked her.

"Honestly, I'm not really sure myself what the monster is, but it has red skin and emits chaotic energy like demons, so they are most likely another species of demons."

"Another species? Demons have different species...?" Yuan was speechless. Why hasn't he heard about this until now?

"Anyways, you only need to know that they are more dangerous than ordinary demons, and nobody has ever defeated it before, but maybe you can. Good luck."

Yan Hara stopped talking after that.

"I get a thousand points if I defeat it, which is definitely a lot of points and will secure my victory, but nobody has managed to do so in the past..." Yuan began pondering.

"Young Master, you only need to defeat it, right? That means you don't need to kill it, only seal it. If you continue hitting it with your demon sealing techniques, it'll eventually be sealed, right?" Feng Yuxiang said.

"You're right. Since it has such a massive body, it will be easy to land hits on it. Okay, I will do it." Yuan decided to fight the Abomination. After taking a deep breath, he turned around and returned to the location with the Abomination.

However, he didn't immediately start attacking the Abomination. Instead, he sat down in an isolated area and started preparing himself for the fight.

Fortunately for him, the Abomination seemed to be asleep, as it was just sitting there with its eyes closed.

A few minutes later, Yuan opened his eyes that were overflowing with fighting intent.

He stood up and looked at the Abomination with a resolute gaze. After taking a very deep breath, Yuan summoned the Starry Abyss and used Ten Thousand Ghost Blades on it, duplicating the Starry Abyss 2,000 times.

Once he was ready, Yuan commanded all 2,000 Starry Abyss to attack the sleeping monster.

The next moment, all 2,000 daggers stabbed into the sleeping monster's round body, turning it into a porcupine.

However, the Abomination remained still, almost as though it didn't even feel the attack.

Seeing the lack of reaction from the Abomination, Yuan decided to continue stabbing it, slowly filling it with demon sealing aura.

Of course, since it was a demon, the holes on its body would immediately renergate the moment the daggers were removed from its body.

"What's going on? It's been ten minutes since I started attacking it, yet it still hasn't woken up, nor does it appear to be sealed. Even a Demon General would be sealed by now..." Yuan scratched his head as he continued commanding the Starry Abyss to attack the Abomination.

"I think you need something stronger." Lan Yingying's voice suddenly resounded.

"Huh? What do you mean? Although each attack doesn't inflict much demon sealing aura individually, it should add up, right? It worked on other demons." Yuan said

"Yes, but that demon appears to have some sort of ability that prevents demon sealing aura from building up inside its body. I can sense your demon sealing aura entering the demon's body, but I can also sense it coming out of its body after some time."

"That's ridiculous..." Yuan did not want to believe that a demon with such capabilities could possibly exist, as that would make it many times harder to seal the demon, perhaps even impossible.

Eventually, Yuan created 10,000 copies of the Starry Abyss and attacked the sleeping Abomination with them.

"How about now? Is it affecting the demon?" Yuan asked Lan Yingying a few minutes later.

"It is, but not fast enough. At this rate, you'll need to continue this for a week before it shows any results," she said.

"A week?" Yuan was speechless.

His spiritual energy would most likely run out before a week could even pass.

After trying for a few more minutes, Yuan recalled the Starry Abyss and gave up on attacking the Abomination temporarily to recover his spiritual energy.

'What should I do now? My Starry Abyss is basically useless in this situation, and the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike won't be able to kill it. Do I really have no means to defeat this monster?' Yuan pondered for a way to defeat the Abomination while he cultivated.

Suddenly, he recalled a certain moment that he witnessed not long ago.

'During the demon sealing tournament, the Leader of the Demon Sealing Clan infused his demon sealing aura with his Sword Aura— at least that's what the triplets said... If I can somehow replicate that, would I be able to defeat the Abomination with it? But how do I even infuse my demon sealing aura with my Sword Aura?'

'Hey, Divine Paragon, give me some guidance. I know you're in here somewhere.] Yuan began calling for the Divine Paragon inside his head.

Unfortunately, there was no response from the Divine Paragon.

'He said that he doesn't really exist and that he's only a fragment of my memories, so I should be able to draw out those memories, right? Maybe if I look deeper inside my consciousness...'

Yuan stopped cultivating after recovering enough spiritual energy, but he did not open his eyes.

"Young Master? Are you okay?" Feng Yuxiang asked him when she saw no movements from him.

"Please be quiet for a while, I am trying to focus." Yuan responded in a low voice.

"S-Sorry..."

Once it was completely silent, Yuan tried to enter deep within his consciousness to find the Divine Paragon.

When he was still a cripple, in order to not go crazy from boredom since he couldn't move his body and was surrounded by darkness, Yuan learned how to peer deep into his mind so that he could relive his memories— in a time before he was a cripple.

After doing it for many years, he got so good at it that he could essentially see any memories he wanted at will, and this included memories that were hidden deep within his consciousness with some limitations, such as memories from before he became an orphan, as he had zero memories of such a time inside his mind.

Although he hasn't tried doing it after regaining his ability to move, he was still able to enter the depths of his consciousness with ease.

Once he entered the deepest parts of his consciousness, Yuan could see four people standing beside each other.

There was Tian Yang, the Divine Paragon, the Evil God, and even the spear-wielding General that appeared in his dream once.

"Look who we have here..."

Their familiar voices resounded inside Yuan's head as he approached these figures that had the same face as him..

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Chapter 839: Divine Paragon's Legacy

Chapter 839: Divine Paragon's Legacy

"So this is where you all have been hiding... I should have done this earlier..." Yuan sighed when he saw these four people deep within his consciousness.

"What do you seek by coming here?" Tian Yang asked him.

"I want..." Yuan turned to look at the Divine Paragon and spoke, "I want to learn how to infuse my demon sealing aura with my Sword Aura. I want to defeat that Abomination."

"The Abomination, huh? What a nostalgic name." The Divine Paragon closed his eyes with a profound smile on his face.

"You want my knowledge; my experience; my memories... but are you prepared to accept my existence?" The Divine Paragon suddenly opened his eyes and stepped forward.

"We may be one and the same, but we are also different people— at least until you accept the fact that we're the same."

"If you are not prepared to accept my existence, then you are not prepared to receive my legacy."

"..."

Yuan was speechless.

He didn't think that he'd be rejected of his own memories unless he agreed with his own incarnation.

"What will happen if I accept you? Will you completely take over my existence? Will I return to being the 'Divine Paragon'?" Yuan asked him.

The Divine Paragon smiled and said, "Remember, you're not just accepting my memories. If you truly want to see 'me', you'll need to be 'me'. Of course, that doesn't mean you'll actually become me."

"And what will happen if I refuse to accept you?" Yuan asked out of curiosity.

"Nothing really happens. You can reject all of our existence for now, but you'll eventually fully awaken your memories. You cannot run away forever, Yuan. There will be a time when you'll have to embrace your true identity, and you'll only make it harder on yourself the longer you delay the inevitable."

Yuan silently stared at the four figures before him after hearing the Divine Paragon's words.

A few moments later, he asked, "If... What if you're not really my memories but memories that were planted inside my mind?"

The Divine Paragon exchanged glances with the others.

"Hahaha!"

All four of them suddenly burst out laughing.

"Do you really believe that? Is this because of what that phoenix said? Even without the Pill of Truth, you should know very well if we are real or fake." Tian Yang said.

Yuan sighed inwardly. Even without Tian Yang mentioning it, he already knew that these were his true memories.

"Well? Have you come to a conclusion yet?" The Divine Paragon asked him a moment later.

After a moment of silence, Yuan nodded his head.

"Even if I accept you, I will still be myself. I will make sure of that," he said in a resolute voice.

"That's what I like to hear."

A bright smile appeared on the Divine Paragon's face as he approached Yuan some more.

Once they were standing right in front of each other, the Divine Paragon extended his hand out for a handshake.

"My legacy... I will leave it in your hands. Don't disappoint me." The Divine Paragon said

"I will try not to." Yuan nodded before accepting the Divine Paragon's handshake.

The Divine Paragon suddenly began glowing, shattering into countless tiny fragments a few seconds later. These tiny fragments were his memories, and they combined with Yuan. 0

Memories began flowing inside Yuan's mind— his early memories as the Divine Paragon.

However, these were still just a small fraction of the Divine Paragon's memories.

Of course, even one percent of the Divine Paragon's memories contained a vast amount of experience and knowledge that could make a mortal into a god-like existence.

Tears suddenly began flowing from Yuan's eyes as he reclaimed his earlier memories as the Divine Paragon, such as his childhood and the reason he started hunting demons.

"I see... So this is why you— I started hunting demons." Yuan mumbled in a low voice as a beautiful young lady suddenly materialized before him inside his head.

"I'm sorry... Even though I promised that I'd never forget about you." Yuan said to the young lady that stood before him.

"It's okay. Due to your unique circumstances, I will forgive you— only if you do me a favor."

"What is it?"

"Say my name," she said.

A gentle smile appeared on Yuan's face as he spoke, "Ai Rong."

The young lady showed him a beautiful smile that could make even dead flowers blossom after hearing her name.

"Since you have proven that you truly remember me, I will forgive you. However, more importantly, do you remember your own name?"

Yuan nodded, "Yes. I was called Tian Chenyu before I became the Divine Paragon."

"That's right. But that doesn't matter anymore because..."

"Because I am not Tian Chenyu. I am Yuan." He finished Ai Rong's sentence.

The beautiful young lady gently nodded her head before disappearing into the void.

Yuan turned to look at the other three incarnations of him.

"Do I have to accept you guys as well?" He asked them.

"Eventually, but now is not the time. You will need time to fully digest Tian Chenyu's memories before you absorb our memories as well. Don't bite

more than you can chew, or you'll go insane." Tian Yang said.

And he continued, "Also, don't rush trying to recall all of your memories. The memories of an immortal that has lived for millions of years is not something to be taken lightly. Even a tiny fragment could be tens of thousands of years of experience, which is more than enough to overwhelm someone with just 18 years of experience."

"I understand." Yuan nodded.

He opened his eyes a moment later to find that they were still flowing with tears.

"Are you okay, Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang asked him.

"Yes, I am fine. I just remembered something sad that happened really long ago."

Feng Yuxiang didn't completely understand the meaning behind his words, but she decided to not ask him about it.

"Anyways, let's deal with this Abomination and get back to farming more points, shall we?" Yuan stood up and turned to look at the sleeping monster with a calm gaze, his demeanor completely different from just minutes ago..

Chapter 840: Swords of Eternal Torment

Chapter 840: Swords of Eternal Torment

Even though only a few moments have passed since Yuan returned, both Feng Yuxiang and Lan Yingying noticed the change in Yuan's demeanor.

He appeared more calm and nonchalant, but they could not pinpoint exactly what was so different about him.

In their eyes, he was still the Yuan they knew, but at the same time, he appeared to be a different person.

Meanwhile, Yuan summoned the Empyrean Overlord and began approaching the Abomination.

"What's he doing? Why is he getting so close to the Abomination?" Tang Zheng asked out loud when he saw Yuan's action.

"Who knows. Maybe he has something up his sleeves." Yan Hara shrugged.

Once Yuan was directly before the Abomination, he looked up at the demon that was almost the size of a mountain and showed a profound smile on his face.

"Abominations, also known as Mutated Demons They are not only harder to kill than normal demons but they are also extremely chaotic. Without a mind of their own, they act only upon their own instincts, which tells them to destroy everything in their path. They cannot discern between friends and foes, so they attack even other demons if they are within its path. A truly unforgiving existence that shouldn't be allowed to exist."

Yuan slowly liked the Empyrean Overlord until it was directly above his head.

After taking a deep breath, he slashed the enormous sword that suddenly erupted with a massive amount of Sword Aura at the sleeping demon.

Whoosh!

The Sword Aura pierced straight inside the Abomination's body before it began expanding and erasing everything that it touched.

The Abomination that had been sleeping peacefully suddenly snapped its eyes and mouth wide open before releasing an ear-piercing scream that shook the entire Demons' Valley.

When Wan Kaiqi and the other participant heard the Abomination's screaming, they immediately stopped whatever they were doing and turned to have the direction of the noise.

'Only the Abomination would make a sound like that! Who is fighting it? Daoist Huan? It must be her! There's no way it could be that pipsqueak!' Wan Kaiqi quickly started making his way towards the Abomination's direction.

The only other participant also started making her way towards the noise due to her curiosity.

So someone else beside me also wanted to fight the Abomination, huh?' She thought to herself.

Meanwhile, Yuan continued his assault on the Abomination.

After releasing his Sword Aura that was infused with demon sealing aura woke up the sleeping demon but it also wreaked havoc inside its body.

However, even that was not enough to defeat the demon. "Not enough, huh? Then let's weaken you some more!"

[Swords of Eternal Torment!]

Golden lights shaped like swords began appearing above the Abomination before plunging down, filling the demon's body with holes.

This was the same technique the Divine Paragon used to remove demons' pain tolerance, which was as effective on the Abomination as it would on any other demon.

And sure enough, the Abomination shrieked in pain, something it hasn't experienced before.

The Demons' Valley shook again with even more intensity, and it would not stop, acting like a pig as it was being slaughtered.

"I-Impossible!" Wan Yu cried out loud after seeing Yuan summon the golden swords.

"T-That can't be Swords of Eternal Torment, right?" Yan Hara refused to believe her eyes.

"I don't want to believe it, but it definitely looks like it..." Tang Zheng responded in a dazed voice.

"That's not possible! That technique had disappeared alongside the Divine Paragon! It must be another technique that looks similar!" Wan Yu said.

Swords of Eternal Torment was one of Divine Paragon's signature techniques, and it was one of very few techniques that he did not share with the Demon Sealing Clan, so when he disappeared, so did these techniques.

However, while these techniques no longer exist, records of their existence do, hence why Wan Yu and the others recognized the technique the moment they saw it.

Whether they believe it to be Swords of Eternal Torment is a different story.

"The Abomination appears to be in pain. I have never seen it react like that" Tang Zheng mumbled in a dazed voice.

"But demons can't feel pain." Yan Hara said.

"No, they can't— unless they are affected by Swords of Eternal Torment. According to our ancestors, when the Divine Paragon used that technique, all demons affected by it would experience pain like normal." Wan Yu explained.

"However, that cannot be Swords of Eternal Torment. The Divine Paragon never shared that technique with anyone in the Demon Sealing Clan— not even wills their most trusted members at that time."

"What if the Divine Paragon left behind his legacy before disappearing? What if he's really using Swords of Eternal Torment? What if he found the Divine Paragon's legacy?" Tang Zheng spoke with a serious expression on his face.

"If that's the case and the others find out, there will be a war to acquire it And it won't just be om clans fighting for it The entire Nine Heavens would be participating in this war." Wan To said.

And he continued, "But once again, I do not believe that's the case. The Divine Paragon doesn't strike me as the type of person to leave behind his legacy and disappear without a word."

"Then how do you explain the Abomination's reaction?" Tang Zheng asked.

"It's most likely just agitated. I believe it was also like this when Dian Chu fought it,. he said.

"What about the technique that looks exactly like Swords of Eternal Torment?. "

Do you know how many techniques exist in the Nine Heavens? Countless. There are bound to be techniques that look similar to each other despite being two completely different techniques. I have seen a few of these techniques myself, too."

"I guess so.. But you can't deny how freaky of a coincidence this is. Not only does he look like the Divine Paragon, even his techniques look like

they belong to the Divine Paragon." Tang Zheng laughed out loud when he realized this fact.

"A coincidence or is this fate?" Yan Nara mumbled in a low voice as she stared at Yuan fighting the Abomination with a profound gaze, her thoughts unknown..

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Chapter 841: Fighting the Abomination

"So freaking noisy! Let me help you quiet down!" Yuan swung the Empyrean Overlord, unleashing another wave of Sword Aura at the Abomination.

This time, he aimed for the demon's head.

The instant the Sword Aura touched the demon's head, it was cut until there was almost nothing left, and without a mouth or head, the demon was finally silenced.

However, the silence only lasted for a few moments until the demon regenerated and started screaming again.

"Then how about this!"

Yuan summoned a couple more golden swords before using them to seal the demon's mouth shut by filling its mouth with these swords.

This tactic worked wonders, as the demon was unable to remove the swords.

Once it was quiet again, Yuan returned to attacking the Abomination with his Sword Aura.

Even though his attacks did not seem to work at first, Yuan eventually noticed that the Abomination's recovery rate was beginning to lag.

Eventually, the Abomination gave up on trying to remove the golden swords and started thrashing around, and since its face was covered in

golden swords, it could only blindly attack its surroundings like a broken machine.

The landscape quickly began to change with the Abomination's chaotic movements.

The Abomination's erratic movements also forced Yuan to slow down his attacks so that he doesn't get hit by its random attacks.

Wan Kaiqi eventually arrived at the scene, and when he saw that it was Yuan who had been fighting the Abomination this entire time, he was left speechless and completely shocked.

"I-Impossible What technique did he use to cover the Abomination with those golden swords?"

Then he noticed that Yuan was attacking the Abomination with Sword Aura that had been infused with demon sealing aura.

"He can not only use Sword Aura but also infuse it with demon sealing aura?! Who is this guy?! There's no way he's just a mere Spirit Lord! He must be hiding his true cultivation! Fuck! He tricked me!"

It was at this moment that Wan Kaiqi realized the points he'd painstakingly acquired were at stake.

However, no matter how much he wanted to return to hunting demons, he was just unable to leave. There was something about Yuan fighting with the Abomination that is keeping him there.

Daoist Huan showed up a few minutes after Wan Kaiqi, and sure enough, she was just as shocked as Wan Kaiqi after she saw the situation.

"W-Who is that?" She asked Wan Kaiqi without taking her eyes off the fight.

"I don't know," he responded in a confused voice.

He was just as clueless as her.

Eventually, the Abomination began showing signs of being sealed, as one of its arms had turned into stone completely.

When he saw this, Yuan briefly stopped his attacks and began gathering spiritual energy in his sword.

After taking a deep but calm breath, Yuan released the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike on the Abomination. Of course, this Heaven Splitting Sword Strike was infused with demon sealing aura just like his Sword Aura.

Of course, this Heaven Splitting Sword Strike was infused with demon sealing aura just like his Sword Aura.

The Heaven Splitting Sword Strike easily blew a massive hole within the Abomination's body like a sharp knife cutting paper before disappearing in the horizon.

The Abomination's body immediately began working on recovering the damage, but it realized that it was unable to heal the wound just as quickly.

Its instincts told the Abomination that it was in danger, and for the first time, it gave up on destruction and focused on running away.

.."I-It's running away? No way... " Wan Kaiqi was bewildered by the Abomination's actions.

The others watching were just as baffled, as they have never witnessed such a scene before.

'Where do you think you're going?!'

Yuan stopped attacking the demon and took a moment to create a massive golden sword that was almost as big as the Abomination before sending it flying at the Abomination.

BOOM!

The entire world shook as the golden sword pinned the Abomination into the ground, stopping it from running away.

The Abomination wanted to scream in pain, but since it couldn't make any noises, its body began squirming instead...

If you stop struggling and become sealed, you won't have to endure any more pain!. Yuan shouted at the demon as he unleashed some more Sword Aura at the pinned down demon.

Eventually, the Abomination could no longer regenerate faster than it was being sealed and completely turned into stone.

Seeing that he'd finally sealed the Abomination, Yuan finally stopped attacking it and sat down to recover his spiritual energy that was almost exhausted.

The place turned dead silent after Yuan sealed the Abomination, and even the demons that had been in hiding did not dare to disturb him. Despite not being real, these demons were created to act and think like demons, so it was only natural for them to fear Yuan after witnessing his display of strength...

"H-He really did it He sealed the Abomination..." Yan Hara muttered in a dazed voice as she stared at the Abomination's sealed frame.

Even though she had a feeling that Yuan had the potential to defeat the Abomination, she still couldn't believe it even after witnessing it happen with her own eyes.

"Shit... I really want to speak with him right now, but we are not allowed to approach them until the examination is over..." Wan Yu gritted his teeth with deep frustration.

While Yuan recovered his spiritual energy, Wan Kaiqi and Daoist Huan would just stand in place and stare at the sealed Abomination as though they were in a trance.

"This cannot be happening... I must be dreaming..." Wan Kaiqi mumbled in a low voice after many minutes of silence.

"I really wish this was just a dream, but..." Daoist Huan released a deep sigh.

She turned around and began walking away.

"Where are you going?" Wan Kaiqi asked her.

"The Abomination may have been defeated, but there are still plenty of demons to hunt," she said before disappearing from his sight.

Wan Kaiqi lingered around for a few more minutes before leaving the place as well.

However, he did not return to hunting demons. Instead, he went straight to the finish line. He knew that his defeat was inevitable, so there was no reason for him to continue farming points, as he would only be helping Yuan gather more points..

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Chapter 842: Promotion to Elite Demon Sealer

"Phew, that took more effort than I'd expected." Yuan sighed in relief after he finished recovering his spiritual energy.

"Young Master... Are you still the Young Master, or are you..." Feng Yuxiang had a feeling that his memories as the Divine Paragon had resurfaced again, affecting his behavior.

Yuan smiled and said, "Don't worry, Feng Feng. It's still me, Yuan."

"Anyways, we still have plenty of time left before the end of the examination. Let's get as many points as we can."

He then stood up and turned to look in a specific direction.

"Why are you hiding? Come out and play with me!" Yuan suddenly said out loud.

When the demons in hiding heard Yuan's words, they immediately turned around and began running away. They knew that they had no chance against a monster like Yuan, who single-handedly defeated the Abomination without giving it the chance to really retaliate.

"Where do you think you're all going? You can run and hide, but you won't escape from me! I can smell you all from miles away!"

A wide smile appeared on Yuan's face as he chased after the demons, feeling better than ever before.

After consuming the Divine Paragon's memories, his hidden fear towards demons disappeared, allowing his confidence to flow and becoming empowered by it.

Although he's never really mentioned it to anyone, he was always fearful of demons inwardly. Perhaps even he was not aware of it, but now that fear is gone, it feels as though a massive amount of weight has been lifted off his back.

[Demon Sealing Strike!]

Yuan used this technique with Sword Aura, shredding the demon it struck until there was nothing left of it, killing it almost instantly.

'The way he uses his Sword Aura... It reminds me of the Lord's Sword Aura.... Lan Yingying thought to herself as she watched Yuan kill one demon after another from his wrist.

A few hours later, Yuan accumulated over 1,500 points.

"At this rate, he'll clear out all of the demons within the Demons' Valley." Tang Zheng said.

"He's going to have a field day Inside the treasure room with the amount of points he'll have by the end of the examination." Wan Yu smiled.

"And he still has another full day to acquire more points..." Yan Hare said.

"Oh well. Even if he empties out the treasure room, nobody can complain about it, as that is the rule of this examination."

After another day of hunting demons, Yan Hara's voice resounded from the necklace, 'You have four hours left before the examination comes to an end.'

"Four hours, huh? Might as well end things now since it appears that I have hunted all of the demons in the Demons' Valley." Yuan mumbled to himself, as it has been over an hour since he last encountered a demon.

Thus, he began making his way towards the finish line.

He reached the Divine Paragon's statue two hours later to see Wan Kaiqi cultivating beside the statue.

When Wan Kaiqi noticed Yuan's presence, he opened his eyes and proceeded to stare at Yuan with a perplexed expression on his face.

Yuan glanced back at Wan Kaiqi and said, "I'm surprised to see you here before me. Did something happen?"

"No particular reason. I just got bored of fighting demons, so I decided to end it early," Wan Kaiqi lied without any hesitation.

And he continued, "Don't worry, I won't go back on my own words. If I lose, I will give you my points as promised."

Yuan didn't really care about Wan Kaiqi's reasons for quitting early, so after hearing that Wan Kaiqi would honor their bet, he stopped bothering Wan Kaiqi and sat down to cultivate.

About an hour after Yuan's arrival, Daoist Huan also showed up at the finish line, but she appeared to be a little agitated for some reason.

'What the heck is going on with the examination? I stopped encountering demons after the second day!' She sighed inwardly.

Although she knew that there was only a limited amount of demons to hunt for the examination, she could not have expected for Yuan to kill all of them within 2 days, hence her frustration and confusion.

However, that confusion would disappear shortly later when the judges appeared to announce the results.

Once all three participants arrived at the finish line, Yan Hera and the other judges showed up to end the examination.

"Congratulations on passing the examination. The three of you will be promoted to the rank of Elite Demon Sealer. We would normally hold a

ceremony for such an occasion, but due to the current situation, we will have to skip the ceremony and go straight to the promotion." Wan Yu said to them.

"Anyways, let's announce the results of the examination."

"Third place, Wan Kaiqi with 155 points."

"Second place, Huan Xie with 289 points."

"First place, Yuan with 2,056 points."

"T-Two thousand points...?" Huan Xie looked at Yuan with her eyes as wide as saucers.

'No wonder why I couldn't find any demons! This guy killed them all!'

Two thousand points... That's gotta be the record... Wan Kaiqi looked at Yuan with a bewildered face.

Indeed, Yuan's two thousand points had beaten the previous record held by Dian Chu, even doubling it. "Do you guys have anything to say before we leave this place?" Wan Yu then asked.

Wan Kaiqi raised his hands and said, "My points... Give them to him."

"What?" Wan Yu raised his eyebrows in a questioning manner.

"I lost a bet with him." Wan Kaiqi said, not explaining any further.

"Very well. You have a total of 2,211 points now." Wan Yu said to Yuan.

They left the Demons' Valley shortly after and returned to the Grand Library, where Yan Hara handed them their new badges.

"Once again, congratulations," she said to them.

"Thank you, Senior." They bowed to her before taking their leave.

After the other two left, it was Just Yuan and the three Judges.

They turned to look at him and proceeded to stare at him in silence. They had so many questions for him that neither of them knew where to start..

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Chapter 843: Act of Treachery

"Is there something wrong?" Yuan decided to ask them after giving them plenty of time to speak.

"Little founder... That technique you used to restrict the Abomination—what kind of technique is it?" Yan Hara forcefully swallowed before asking him.

"Oh, that was one of my family's techniques. It's called Swords of Binding Light. It's really good for restricting magical beasts and demons alike," he responded in a calm manner.

"Swords of Binding Light? So it really wasn't Swords of Eternal Torment?" Tang Zheng mumbled.

"I told you it couldn't have been that technique." Wan Yu didn't seem surprised outside, but he was relieved inwardly.

Of course, since Yuan had the Divine Paragon's memories, he was well aware that Swords of Eternal Torment was a technique that had never been shared with the Demon Sealing Clan or anyone in that matter. He was also aware of the risk from using the technique, but he had no other choice, as that technique was required to defeat the Abomination at his current level.

"Anyways, that was a marvelous performance, little founder. I am now more confident than ever that you have what it takes to become the next leader of the Demon Sealing Clan!" Yan Hara said with a bright smile on her face.

"Screw the Demon Sealing Clan." Wan Yu suddenly said.

"Huh? What did you just say?" Yan Hare turned to look at him with a frown on her face.

However, Wan Yu ignored her and continued to look at Yuan, "I wouldn't normally do something this shameless, but you're worth it. Yuan, leave the Demon Sealing Clan and join the Demon Sealing Grotto. You're wasting your talents over there."

"Hey! How dare you try to convert the little founder right in front of me!" Yan Hara was beginning to fume in anger.

Wan Yu coldly snorted at her and said, "Have you already forgotten what I told you during the examination? The Demon Sealing Clan is collapsing faster than ever before. It will only be a matter of time before it completely disappears."

He then turned to look at Yuan and continued, "Listen here, Yuan. Because of Qian Chu, the current leader of the Demon Sealing Clan, three Master Demon Sealers from the Demon Sealing Grotto were killed, and this isn't the first time he's indirectly killed our people. The Demon Sealing Grotto can only endure it so much before they make the Demon Sealing Clan pay for its leader's crimes."

"Therefore, I am advising you to leave it before things get too hectic. If you want to become a leader, you can become the leader of the Demon Sealing Grotto instead. I believe you have the capabilities."

After a moment of silence, Yuan spoke, "So what you're saying is... The Demon Sealing Clan will suffer because of the current leader. In other words, as long as someone replaces his position, the Demon Sealing Grotto won't bother us any further. Is that correct?"

"Uhh... I understand where you're coming from, but that's not how this works. Even if the Demon Sealing Grotto is willing to forgive the Demon Sealing Clan, it is highly unlikely that someone will replace him. Ojan Chu, he won't let anyone take his position even if he has to fight to his last breath."

"Little founder, are you thinking about taking Qian Chu's spot as the leader of the Demon Sealing Clan?" Yan Hara suddenly asked him.

"Hm? No, not at all. However, I do intend on removing Wan Chu from his position. He doesn't qualify to be the leader of the Demon Sealing Clan." Yuan said in a calm voice.

Yan Hara and Tang Zheng felt chills down their spine after hearing Yuan's words, and they immediately began looking around to make sure nobody else had heard him.

"Y-You shouldn't say such things out loud! Do you have any idea how many people admire Qian Chu? Even worse, if Qian Chu gets word of it, he will personally take care of you!" Yan Hara warned him.

"Hahaha!" Wan Yu suddenly began laughing out loud.

"You are truly a wondrous and incomprehensible existence! Tell me, how are you going to 'remove him'? You have piqued my interest!"

"Don't tell him anything. For all we know, he could run off to tell Qian Chu afterward." Yan Hara sneered.

"I would never help Can Chu. He's not only an egotistical bastard but also coldhearted to the bone. He's someone that could sacrifice an entire city without batting an eye as long as he achieves his goal, almost like a demon in human skin. If I can assist in bringing him down, I would do so in a heartbeat." Wan Yu shook his head.

And he continued, "You know, I had a relationship with many of the demon sealers that had been killed by Qian Chu. They were my friends."

Yuan then spoke, "Even if you ask me to tell you, I don't know how to remove him from his position— at least not right now. However, I will eventually think of something."

"Little founder... Are you serious?" Yan Hara looked at him with a worried frown on her pretty face.

"It is one thing to fight for his position, but what you're doing sounds like an act of treachery... You could—will be killed for it if caught."

"Don't worry, Senior Yan. I won't do anything... for now. After all, I am still too weak to threaten anybody." Yuan said.

"Aiya... That's not what I am worried about..."

"You worry too much, Yan Hara. If you keep your mouth shut, nobody will find out about anything. In fact, the two of you are more of a risk to him than I am. After all, you're both from the Demon Sealing Clan and work directly for Qian Chu. I, on the other hand, work for the side that wants to see him fall."

"That's it! I have had enough of your bullshit! How dare you suggest that I would do anything to hurt him!"

Just as Yan tiara prepared to confront Wan Yu, Tang Zheng quickly reacted and stepped between them.

"That's enough from the both of you. Are you trying to worsen the already grave situation between our clans? If you don't trust each other, I have a suggestion. Make an oath with heaven as witness that you will not say anything."

"You want us to make a Heavenly Oath?" They looked at Tang Zheng with wide eyes.

"It's either that or you continue fighting each other." Tang Zheng nodded.,

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Chapter 844: Heavenly Oath

"If it makes things better, I can go first." Tang Zheng said when he noticed their hesitancy.

However, they weren't hesitant because they had planned on telling Qian Chu about Yuan's plan to remove him from his position.

They were hesitant because a Heavenly Oath would mark their soul, and anything that is related to the soul is an extreme risk for any cultivators. Unless it was absolutely necessary, nobody would dare to take such risks.

"I-I am willing to do a Heavenly Oath since I know that I won't say anything." Yan Hara said a moment later.

"If you do it, then I will do it as well." Wan Yu nodded.

Yuan then said, "You guys really don't need to do this... If I didn't trust you guys, I wouldn't have said anything out loud."

"Little founder, this is not just about you. This is also about our trust for each other. He clearly doesn't trust me, but I don't blame him since I don't trust him either." Yan Hara said.

Wan Yu nodded, agreeing with Yan Hara's words.

"Then allow me to start."

Tang Zheng raised his hand above his head and spoke, "With Heaven as my witness, I swear that I will not tell anyone that isn't here right now about what just happened. If I break this oath, may the Heavens shatter my soul as punishment."

A golden light flickered on Tang Zheng's forehead the next second, which meant that the Heavenly Oath was a success.

Yan Hara and Wan Yu followed suit after Tang Zheng by making their own oath.

"There. Are you happy now?" Van Hara glared at Wan Yu afterward.

"Yes, very happy." Wan Yu shrugged.

He then turned to look at Yuan and said, "Anyways, if you truly intend on removing Wan Chu from his position, don't wait too long because the Demon Sealing Grotto definitely won't be waiting for you."

Yuan nodded, and he asked, "Do you know when the Demon Sealing Grotto might act?"

"Well, as heated as things are right now, I doubt anything significant would happen for a few more years. This is a very sensitive situation that could result in war between the two clans. However, I wouldn't bet on anything. We don't know what Qian Chu has planned, after all."

"I will figure something out. You guys can just continue your life as normal." Yuan said.

"Normal, huh? I think it's a little too late for that Tang Zheng sighed.

"What are you going to do now?" Yan Hara asked him.

"I am going to focus on increasing my own strength," he said.

"If you need anything, you can contact me."

"Anyways, do you want to visit the treasury now to redeem your points, or do you want to do it later? You have one year to use them before they are no longer valid." Wan Yu asked him sometime later.

"I want to do it now." Yuan said.

"Alright. Follow us."

Yuan nodded and proceeded to follow them to this secluded area behind the Grand Library, where a small pagoda was located.

Sitting In front of this building was an old man, who appeared to be cultivating.

Once they got close enough, the old man opened his eyes and spoke without opening his mouth, his calm voice resounding very clearly in their heads, "What do you want?"

"He's here to redeem his points." Wan Yu said.

The old man narrowed his gaze at Yuan for a moment before gesturing for him.

"Go ahead. Well wait for you out here." Yan Hara said to him.

Yuan nodded and approached the old man

"Show me your necklace."

Yuan removed the necklace from the examination and handed it to the old man.

"Hm?!"

The old man's eyes widened with surprise after seeing how many points Yuan had acquired.

He turned to look at Yan Hara and the others with a look of disbelief on his face.

"It's real, Senior." Wan Yu said with a smile on his face.

'There should only be enough demons within the Demons' Valley to acquire 1,500 points, but the fact that you have 2,211 points must mean that you

have managed to defeat the Abomination..." The old man muttered in a low voice.

He then placed the necklace on his forehead and closed his eyes.

The necklace suddenly began glowing, and Yuan's fight with the Abomination that it had recorded replayed inside the old man's head.

"The technique you used to create those golden swords... What Is it called?" The old man asked Yuan with a serious expression on his face.

"Swords of Binding Light." Yuan responded without hesitation.

"Are you sure it's not called Swords of Eternal Torment?" The old man narrowed his eyes.

"Swords of Eternal Torment? What's that?" Yuan raised his eyebrows in a puzzled manner, looking like he'd genuinely never heard of such a technique before.

Seeing Yuan's reaction, the old man shook his head, "Forget it."

'Somebody probably took inspiration from Swords of Eternal Torment for their own technique. It happens quite often.... He sighed inwardly.

"Alright, follow me." The old man stood up and led Yuan into the pagoda.

Once inside the pagoda, Yuan was greeted by hundreds of treasures on display on the ground and even on the walls.

"You have an hour. Do not touch any of the treasures. They are protected by a powerful array. If you want a treasure, let me know, unless you want to experience the power of these arrays." The old man said to him.

Yuan nodded and immediately began looking at the demon sealing treasures.

Most of the treasures there required between too to 500 points, so Yuan could potentially acquire 20 treasures from that place if he picked only the

cheapest treasures.

However, he didn't do that. In fact, he wasn't interested in any of the treasures there.

After a quick walkthrough around the room, Yuan turned to look at the old man and said, "None of these treasures interest me. I want to take a look at the treasures on the next floor..."

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Chapter 845: Demon Warding Talisman

"None of the treasures here interests you? You're a picky one, aren't you?"
The old man laughed out loud.

This is his first time meeting someone who couldn't be swayed by the treasures on the first floor.

"Either the three outside didn't tell you or you just don't care, but you do not qualify to see the other floors." The old man then said.

"But..."

He closed his eyes to ponder.

After a few moments of silence, he spoke, "But since you managed to defeat the Abomination and seem to have a bright future ahead of you, I will make this an exception and allow you to claim a treasure from the next floor."

"Thank you, senior." Yuan clasped his hands and bowed to him in a respectful manner.

"Don't thank me just yet. I said 'a' treasure, so you will only be allowed to choose one treasure even if you have enough points for more. If you stay down here, you can buy as many treasures as you'd like. What is your decision?"

"I would still like to see the next floor." Yuan immediately responded without hesitation.

None of the treasures on this floor were good enough in his eyes, so it wouldn't matter if he could buy multiple of them.

'Very well Follow me.' The old man nodded. and he proceeded to walk to the next floor with Yuan following right behind him.

A few moments Later. Yuan stepped foot inside the second floor. Although there were far Less treasures on this floor at glance, there was a powerful pressure on this floor that didn't exist on the first floor, and it made it harder to breathe for Yuan, as his cultivation level was too weak to stand beside these powerful. treasures.

However. he endured the intense pressure and began walking around the room.

There were swords, spears, bows, daggers— all sorts of weapons on this floor, but none of them interested him.

'These treasures would've definitely been enough before I acquired the Divine Paragon's memories, but now... They just feel so lackluster...' Yuan sighed inwardly.

After reaching the end of the room, Yuan suddenly stopped before a red ring that had been resting inside a display Case for an unknown amount of time.

He didn't recognize this ring, but he had a feeling that he had seen it before.

"What is this treasure?" Yuan decided to ask the old man.

The old man approached him and the treasure before speaking, "Nobody really knows the usage for this treasure or how to use it but it used to belong to the Divine Paragon— at least according to the rumors. There is no concrete proof that it belongs to the Divine Paragon, but some people during his era claimed that they have seen him with it."

"How much is it?" Yuan asked then asked.

He figured that the reason he felt like he had seen the ring before was because it belonged to the Divine Paragon.

'I probably don't recognize it because I don't have the memories for it yet, but I do believe that it belonged to the Divine Paragon. As for its purpose... I will find out once I regain those memories. Hopefully, its worth it He thought to himself.

"It's worth 2.000 points." The old man said.

"That expensive? Even though it doesn't have any usage?" Yuan was surprised to hear this.

"Well, anything related to the Divine Paragon is extremely valuable even it it has no real uses. Even wooden branch that had been touched by Divine Paragon for a brief moment can be worth more than actual. treasures. There are some collectors out there that are obsessed with this kind of stuff." The old man explained.

"I understand that but you just said it is just a rumor that it belonged to the Divine Paragon. What if it turns out to be some random ring?" Yuan asked.

"Even if that is the case, this ring has some value, as it contains massive amount of demon sealing aura within it The only problem is... nobody knows how to extract it or use it How about this. If you decide to buy this treasure. I will change the rules a bit and Let you buy another treasure from the first floor."

"Dear." Yuan immediately agreed.

"Then it's decided that you want this ring?" The old man asked for confirmation.

"Yes, I want this ring:. He confirmed.

"Very well."

The old man then removed the array protecting the display case and retrieved the red ring from within before handing it to Yuan.

Ding!

<You have acquired 'Unknown Sealed Ring'>

[Sealed Ring]

[Grade: ???]

[Description: A mysterious ring that is said to belong to the Divine Paragon, Founder of the Demon Sealing Clan. It contains a massive amount of demon sealing aura within.]

"You have 211 more points."

Yuan returned to the first floor with the old man.

After looking through the treasures once more, Yuan pointed at a specific treasure that was priced at 200 points.

"I want this treasure." Very wen." The old man handed the treasure Yuan picked to him shortly after removing the array.

<You have acquired 'Demon Warding Talisman'>

[Demon Warding Talisman]

[Grade: Divine]

[Description: Activating the Demon Warding Talisman will create a powerful barrier around the user, preventing most demons from approaching. It can also be used to contain demons. Requires 24 hours before it can be activated again.]

"Since you have 11 points left that cannot be used to purchase anything, I will exchange them for spiry stones. Hem you go."

The old man handed Yuan a storage pouch that contained 11.000 spirit stones.

"Thank you." Yuan bowed to the old man afterward.

"I have a feeling that we will be seeing each other again soon. Good Luck, young demon seater" The old man sent Yuan away with a profound smile on his face.

After Leaving the pagoda. Yuan returned to the others that had been waiting outside this entire time.

"What did you get? Show me!" Yan Hare asked him in a curious voice the moment he returned..

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Chapter 846: The Real Demons' Valley

Chapter 846: The Real Demons' Valley

"I picked these two treasures." Yuan showed Yan Hara and the others his new treasures.

"Huh? Only two treasures? That's not right. You had over 2,000 points!" Yan Hara said with a puzzled look on her face.

"That should be the Demon Sealing Ward, and it was only 200 points the last time I saw it. However, I don't recognize that ring."

"I know that ring, but it belonged to the second floor. I'm surprised the old man allowed you to go upstairs since only Master Demon Sealers qualify to go there." Wan Yu said.

And he continued, "But why did you choose that treasure out of everything you could've picked from that floor? I am going to be honest—you wasted your points on that ring."

"What kind of demon sealing treasure is that?" Yan Hara asked.

"It's not really a demon sealing treasure. It is rumored to belong to the Divine Paragon, but there is no real evidence to back up such a rumor. That ring also has a massive amount of demon sealing aura stored within it, but nobody knows how to extract it from the ring. In fact, nobody even knows how to use the ring or what it's used for."

"H-How many points did you spend on this ring?" Yan Hara asked Yuan in a nervous voice.

"2,000 points..." He said.

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"Two thousand?!" Yan Hara exclaimed.

"Heavens! Little founder, how could you waste so many points on such a worthless ring! That shrewd old man must've tricked you into buying it with some bullshit, right?! Come with me! We are going to ask for a refund!"

"Calm down, senior. I was not tricked. I know about the rumors and that nobody knows how to use it." Yuan quickly said.

"A-And you still purchased it? Why would you do such a thing?" Yan Hara asked with a bewildered look on her face.

2,000 points is no small amount. In fact, this is the first time that someone has acquired this many points, yet he wasted it on a useless ring that has no real practical uses when he could've claimed a powerful demon sealing treasure instead? It didn't make any sense.

"To be completely honest, I don't know why I got it. I just had a feeling that I needed it."

"You got it because of a gut feeling...? Unbelievable..." Yan Hara was truly speechless now.

"You know what they say... The more talented they are, the more eccentric. That is why ordinary people can never understand geniuses." Wan Yu shrugged.

"Whatever..." Yan Hara rubbed her temples and sighed.

"Anyways, if it's your choice to pick that ring, then I won't say anything else. I really hope you don't regret it."

Yuan nodded.

Sometime later, Yuan walked outside the Grand Library with the other three.

"Senior, I am going to return in a month to challenge the Demon Sealing Pagoda again. I have a feeling that I am going to defeat the fourth floor this

time." Yuan said.

"A month, right? I understand. You have my communication jade slip, anyway."

"See you later, Yuan."

After saying their goodbyes, Yuan left the Grand Library and returned to Spirit Heaven.

"Do you really think he has what it takes to remove Qian Chu from his position?" Wan Yu asked the other two afterward.

And he continued, "I have my own hopes, but I don't have any expectations."

"He will, without doubt, become the next leader. I will make sure of it. That has been my goal even before today." Yan Hara calmly responded.

Tang Zheng then spoke, "He definitely has the talent, but I don't know if he'll have the time..."

"In the end, we can only hope that fate will guide him towards the right path."

After returning to the Myriad of Techniques, Yuan sighed inwardly, 'The Demon Sealing Clan and the Demon Sealing Grotto... How troublesome...'

Even though he said that he will remove Qian Chu from his position, it was much easier said than done. In the end, he can only put that thought behind his mind for now and focus on getting stronger.

Upon leaving the Myriad of Techniques, Yuan was greeted by a dark sky and the same chilling sensation from the Demons' Valley during the examination.

As he left the narrow alleyway and entered the street, Yuan could hear joyful laughter resounding from the street.

"Did the people of this city finally decide to leave their houses?" Yuan muttered to himself.

Feng Yuxiang appeared beside him and said, "Please be careful, Young Master. I sense something off about them."

Yuan nodded as he entered the street with Feng Yuxiang following close behind him.

He looked around to see many masked people dancing and singing on the street, almost as though there was an active festival, but the atmosphere did not feel normal, like there was something eerie about it.

"Young Master, let's just go straight to the Demons' Valley." Feng Yuxiang said to him.

Yuan nodded, "Yes, let's go."

However, right as he was prepared to leave, the people there suddenly stopped dancing, and they all turned to look at him in silence.

Yuan swallowed nervously, and he quickly said, "Feng Feng, let's just fly out of here."

And before the people there could even react, Yuan flew into the sky and disappeared from their view.

Once in the air, Yuan and Feng Yuxiang began flying towards the Demons' Valley.

"We should be able to see the Demons' Valley very soon." Feng Yuxiang said.

Half an hour later, deformed mountains started popping up in the horizon.

Once Yuan could see the Demons' Valley more clearly, he said, "This place looks nothing like the Demons' Valley from the examination..."

Compared to the Demons' Valley in the Grand Library that had normal-looking mountains, the mountains in this place were mostly deformed, like they had been crushed by giants, and some of them were even riddled with holes.

There was also not a single living tree or blade of grass to be seen, and the miasma was so thick that one could see it with their bare eyes in the form of a red fog that shrouded the Demons' Valley..

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Chapter 847: Suspicious Woman

"This red fog is probably the reason the people in the nameless town are losing their minds..." Yuan mumbled in a low voice.

"How are you feeling, Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang asked him.

"My legs feel a little cold, but that's about it."

"Young Master, can you hold my hands for a moment?" She suddenly extended her hand for him.

Yuan didn't think too much about it and held her hand.

The very next moment, Yuan could feel a burning yet comfortable sensation flowing throughout his body, and the cold feeling in his legs quickly disappeared.

"What was that?" Yuan asked her.

"I just used my phoenix flames to warm up your body. Your veins are burning with my phoenix flames right now, which is warding off the miasma."

"B-Burning?" Yuan's eyes widened.

He wasn't worried that it could hurt him. It was just terrifying to think that his body was literally burning on the inside.

"Don't worry, Young Master. It won't hurt you." Feng Yuxiang chuckled at his reaction.

"I know. But it still feels weird." Yuan said.

"Yingying, are you okay with the miasma?" He asked her.

"Yes, I am fine. Just like Miss Feng, I am not affected by it. In fact, the miasma is actually trying to avoid me. It's probably because of my Sacred Flame."

"Sacred Flames..."

According to the Divine Paragon's memories, besides demon sealing aura, there exists another element in this world that can effectively destroy demons, and that element exists within Lan Yingying's Sacred Flames—divine attribute.

Not much is known about divine attributes since it is a power that cannot be wielded by human cultivators. In fact, only Divine Beasts have ever wielded such powers before.

"Young Master." Feng Yuxiang suddenly called for him.

"There is a person ahead." She pointed at a middle-aged woman who was pacing back and forth the entrance of the Demons' Valley, and she appeared to be very distraught.

When Yuan saw her expression, he couldn't help but feel pity for her.

"Let's see what happened."

"Be careful... She might be from the nameless town..." Feng Yuxiang quickly warned him.

"I don't sense anything wrong with her. It should be fine." Yuan nodded.

He descended before the woman a moment later and asked her, "Excuse me, are you okay?"

The middle-aged woman was startled by Yuan's sudden appearance, but when she realized that he was a cultivator, she immediately approached him and asked, "I-Immortal Cultivator! Are you heading inside the Demons' Valley?!"

"Yes, I am."

"Please! Can you please help me?! My son went inside the Demons' Valley a week ago to hunt magical beasts with his friends, and he promised that he would be home two days ago, but he still hasn't returned! I tried looking for his friends, but they are also missing! I am worried to death that something might've happened to him!" The woman pleaded with him.

"Uhh..."

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As cruel as it may sound, Yuan had a feeling that her son was no longer in this world. However, he didn't want to say it to the already-grieving mother, so he asked, "Do you know where he usually hunts? I can take a look around that area, and if I find him, I will bring him back to you."

"Oh! Thank you! Thank you very much! My son usually hunts near the 'Red Pond'. I will definitely repay this debt!"

Yuan nodded, "This might take a while, so you can return home for now."

"It's okay, I will wait here just in case my son comes out by himself!" She said.

"Are you sure? This place is very dangerous even for cultivators, much less a mortal like you..." Yuan expressed his worries.

The woman nodded and said, "I have been here for two days now. I think I will be fine for another day or two."

"If you say so... I will try to be back before sunrise. Be careful." Yuan said to her.

"I will! Once again, thank you!" The woman bowed to him.

Ding!

<You have accepted a Quest>

[Quest: Grieving Mother's Plea]

[Location: Demons' Valley]

[Difficulty: Hard]

[Description: Search around the 'Red Pond' for the Grieving Mother's missing son]

'A quest, huh? Been a while.' Yuan thought to himself as he glanced over the quest details.

"Are you ready?" Yuan turned to ask Feng Yuxiang, who was staring at the woman with a pondering face.

"Yes, I am ready." Feng Yuxiang nodded.

"Then let's help this woman before we look for our person."

"Okay."

Yuan entered the Demons' Valley with Feng Yuxiang shortly after.

Once they were inside the Demons' Valley and could no longer see the woman, Feng Yuxiang spoke, "Young Master, there's definitely something very weird about that woman."

"What?" Yuan asked.

"Despite being a mortal, she could somehow stand so close to the Demons' Valley without being affected by the miasma. That's not possible." Feng Yuxiang explained.

"Ah, that? I also noticed it, but I didn't sense any bad vibes from her, so I decided to help her anyway." Yuan said.

"Huh? You are still willing to help her even though there's a very good chance that she might be setting a trap for you? That's very reckless of you, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang was dumbfounded.

"Reckless? Maybe. But I really hope it's actually a trap so that I can put an end to it. If I ignore it, this trap will continue to exist and harm others." Yuan said, explaining why he agreed to help the woman.

"Young Master..." Feng Yuxiang did not expect this to be the real reason why Yuan decided to help this suspicious woman.

"Anyways, the Red Pond isn't that far away, so we should arrive soon."

"Huh? How do you know where this place is? Did you acquire a map of this place?" Feng Yuxiang asked.

"Not a map, but it's even better than it." Yuan pointed at his head and smiled, "The Divine Paragon's memories— he's been to this place before, so I also know this place like it's at the back of my hand now."

Feng Yuxiang's mouth dropped wide open.

"A-Are you sure we can trust those memories?"

"I guess we'll find out after we arrive at the location." Yuan chuckled..

Chapter 848: Red Pond

"We have arrived at Red Pond... at least what's left of it." Yuan said as they approached this massive, dried up hole in the ground from the sky.

"This is the Red Pond? There's nothing red about this, and a pond should have water..." Feng Yuxiang raised her eyebrows when she saw the scene.

"Well, that was millions of years ago. That circle used to be a pond filled with red water. Rumors say the red water was actually human blood, and demons used to bathe and drink from it." Yuan sighed.

"Anyways, this proves that my memories can be trusted. What do you think?" He looked at Feng Yuxiang.

"I-I think so too..." She nodded.

"Let's take a look around."

Yuan descended from the sky a moment later, landing right beside the empty pond. However, upon closer inspection, the Red Pond wasn't completely empty, as there appeared to be human remains in the form of bones at the bottom of the pond.

He proceeded to stare at it with a dazed expression on his face.

For more, visit: MtNovel.com

Inside his mind, memories of the Red Pond flowed.

The pond was filled to the brim with crimson liquid that resembled blood, and there were hundreds of demons bathing within the water while the Divine Paragon spied on them from the sky.

'No... The rumor was true. The red water was human blood, and the bottom of this pond was filled with human remains.'

He could still feel the burning emotions the Divine Paragon felt when he first saw the scene of demons bathing in human blood and the horrendous scent that assaulted his nose.

'In order to keep this Red Pond filled, demons killed thousands of people every single day...'

After recalling these highly unpleasant memories, Yuan suddenly felt an urge to puke.

"Young Master, are you okay?" Feng Yuxiang asked him when she noticed his face becoming paler.

"Yes... I just recalled some unpleasant memories, that's all." He said.

Feng Yuxiang held a worried look on her face. Although she doesn't know what kind of memories Yuan was seeing, she knew that it wasn't good for his mental health.

"Anyways, let's look around for that woman's son." Yuan used his divine sense to search for any clues.

"I couldn't find anything— not even a footprint. What about you, Feng Feng?" Yuan asked her a moment later.

She shook her head and said, "I didn't find anything either. This either means the woman was lying about her son, or her son never came to this area."

"Let's expand our search a little more before we come to any conclusions." Yuan said.

"Okay."

They returned to the air shortly after and began flying around the Red Pond.

About half an hour later, they gave up on the search when they found no clues and returned to the Red Pond.

"Let's forget about that woman's missing son... If he even exists..." Feng Yuxiang said.

Yuan sighed, "At the very least, we should let the mother know that we couldn't find him..."

"Okay." Feng Yuxiang nodded.

However, just as Yuan prepared to leave the scene, his body suddenly halted.

"Young Master? What are you waiting for?" Feng Yuxiang asked him from the sky.

After a moment of silence, a slight smile appeared on Yuan's face, and he spoke in a calm voice, "I can smell demons."

"What?" Feng Yuxiang's eyes widened with surprise.

Yuan turned to look in a certain direction and continued, "One... two... three... There are three demons nearby."

"Really? What should we do?"

"Isn't it obvious? I am going to kill them." Yuan responded in a nonchalant manner.

"According to my memories, there is a cave that demons used as a stronghold not far from here. They are probably hiding within this cave."

Now that he's sensed these demons, Yuan immediately began flying towards the direction of their scent.

'How weird. Why didn't I smell their scent before?' Yuan wondered to himself as he quickly approached the demons' scent.

About fifteen minutes later, Yuan stopped moving and gazed upon the cave entrance below him.

"The demons are inside this cave?" Feng Yuxiang asked.

Yuan nodded, and he said, "Yes, but for some reason, their scent is getting weaker..."

Lan Yingying suddenly appeared beside him and said, "There must be something in the cave that conceals their presence and scent."

"Yingying... How are you feeling?" Yuan asked her.

"I am feeling great. I just finished converting all of the magical beasts into spiritual energy, allowing me to breakthrough and become a Spirit Lord."

"Congratulations." Yuan said.

"Thank you, but I am still miles behind Miss Feng and Xiao Hua."

"With your talents, I'm sure you'll catch up to us in no time." Feng Yuxiang smiled.

Lan Yingying nodded, and she turned to look at Yuan, "Allow me to help you with these demons. I want to see my progress."

"Okay." Yuan agreed without any hesitation.

"Thank you."

They descended to the cave entrance a moment later.

"So dark.." Yuan mumbled in a low voice when he couldn't see more than a few inches inside the cave with his bare eyes despite having enhanced senses.

When she heard his words, Feng Yuxiang summoned a ball of flame that hovered above them to light the cave.

"Are you guys ready?" Yuan asked them as he summoned the Empyrean Overlord.

"Ready." They nodded.

And without any hesitation, Yuan walked inside this cave.

Upon entering the cave, Yuan realized that it was filled with skeletons just like the Red Pond.

After walking for a couple of minutes without seeing any signs of demons, they were forced to stop, as the path came to a dead end.

"A dead end? That's not possible... I clearly picked up their scent from this place." Yuan stood there and looked around with a pondering expression on his face.

"What if the demons had already left?" Feng Yuxiang said.

"I would know if they had left, but their scent lingered in this place until it disappeared shortly after we entered this cave. Maybe there is a secret passage or something. Let's look around." Yuan said.

"Okay." They nodded..

Chapter 849: Hidden Passage

Although the cave was quite spacious and wide, it had a linear interior, meaning there was only a single path for Yuan and the others to traverse.

However, even after walking back and forth this cave multiple rounds, they were unable to find any secret passages that the demons could've used to hide themselves.

"I don't see any formations in this place. If there's really a secret passage, it's not concealed by a formation— or it's concealed by a formation that's so powerful that even I cannot see it. However, demons don't have the power to create formations or arrays." Yuan said.

"I also don't see anything out of the ordinary with my divine sense." Feng Yuxiang said.

And she continued in a worried voice, "What if this is a trap? We should probably leave this cave for now."

"Wait." Lan Yingying suddenly said.

"What is it? Do you see something?" Yuan turned to look at her.

"I'm not sure, but that area feels off for some reason— the ground." Lan Yingying pointed at the ground right before the dead end.

"The ground?" Yuan walked over to where Lan Yingying pointed and inspected the ground.

When he couldn't find anything wrong with it, he decided to stomp on the ground.

"Hm?" Yuan raised his eyebrows when he felt a hollow feedback from the stomp.

"It's empty here." He said to them before stabbing into the ground with the Empyrean Overlord.

The ground immediately collapsed, revealing a hidden staircase that led underground.

Furthermore, the scent of demons that had disappeared suddenly appeared again. "I can smell them again! Demons! They're below us!" Yuan quickly said.

"How did we miss such an obvious passage? This must be the work of a treasure that can misdirect our senses. We should be careful, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang warned him.

For more, visit: MtNovel.com

"Good idea, especially since I can smell more than three demons now." Yuan suddenly said.

"Huh? How many demons can you smell?" Feng Yuxiang asked.

After taking a few deep breaths, Yuan replied, "About seven or eight."

"S-Seven or eight? That many?" Lan Yingying was speechless.

"Don't worry, they don't seem very strong. The strongest one appears to be a peak Spirit King, but it's only a low-ranking demon."

"If you say so..." She nodded.

"Young Master, allow me to go first." Feng Yuxiang said.

Yuan nodded, but before walking the staircase, Yuan wore his mask.

"Why the mask?" Feng Yuxiang asked.

"It won't be fun if the demons recognize me," he chuckled.

Feng Yuxiang was speechless.

'He's treating this like a game...' She sighed inwardly.

Sometime later, they began descending the narrow staircase.

Many minutes later, at the end of the staircase, they entered a spacious room with multiple paths to choose from.

"Which way?" Feng Yuxiang turned to look at Yuan, who was already pointing to a path.

"I understand."

Feng Yuxiang, without hesitation, began walking towards the path picked by Yuan.

"I'm surprised you can smell the demons from so far away... How do you do it?" Lan Yingying asked him.

"I don't know. I just instinctively know their location when I smell them, and they have this very distinctive scent that's hard to miss." Yuan shrugged, even though he was unable to smell demons before acquiring the Divine Paragon's memories and experience.

Lan Yingying tried to smell this 'distinctive scent' that Yuan spoke of, but she was not successful.

After walking for ten minutes straight, Feng Yuxiang came to a stop when she arrived at a dead end in the form of a cliff.

However, once they were actually standing on this cliff, they were amazed by the scenery before them.

"This is... a city?" Yuan mumbled in a low voice as he gazed upon a city that had already been reduced to ruins.

Although the city wasn't so large that he couldn't see the end, it was still quite shocking to find a city of this size beneath the Demons' Valley.

'This place isn't in the Divine Paragon's memories, but since I only have a small fraction of his memories, I wouldn't be surprised if he found this place later.' Yuan thought to himself.

After all, if nobody knew about this place, it would still be populated by demons right now.

"What now, Young Master? Should we hunt them one by one— at least until they notice our presence?" Feng Yuxiang asked him.

"No, that would take too much time. We'll gather and deal with all of them at once." Yuan said with an excited smile on his face.

"How are we going to do that?" Feng Yuxiang asked.

"Like this."

Yuan suddenly released his demon sealing aura, instantly filling the entire underground city with his presence.

The very next moment, eight different auras appeared in response to Yuan's provocation.

"They're coming." Yuan warned them.

Feng Yuxiang and Lan Yingying immediately prepared for battle while Yuan continued to stand there in a calm manner, and they watched as eight red-skinned demons emerged from the city before flying towards them.

In less than ten seconds after Yuan announced their presence, all eight demons stood before them.

"How did you find this place, human?" The demon emitting the aura of a peak Spirit King asked.

Yuan pointed at his own face and said, "I followed your scent."

"Our scent? What are you, a dog? No, not even a dog would be able to do that."

And it continued, "Whatever. It doesn't matter how you found this place. It was foolish of you to come here with just the three of you."

"Hahaha! It's been thousands of years since I've tasted human flesh and blood!"

"I call dibs on that woman with the smooth-looking skin beside him! She looks incredibly delicious!" One of the demons suddenly pointed at Lan Yingying.

"Then I want that big-breasted woman! I bet her meat is incredibly tender and juicy!" Another demon laughed as it pointed at Feng Yuxiang.

"Unlike that masked person, they don't smell human. They must be magical beasts disguised as humans."

"Who cares if they are humans or magical beasts! All it matters is how they taste, and I am starving!"

"Let's get 'em!"

However, before the demons could even move two steps, Yuan released his demon sealing aura.

[Demon Sealing Zone!]

With a wave of his sleeve, Yuan confined all eight demons in the Demon Sealing Zone, taking them by surprise.

"W-What the fuck is this?!"

"This feeling... It's the Demon Sealing Zone!"

"What?! The Demon Sealing Zone?! Impossible!"

The demons were confused and terrified at the same time.

After all, only very few people within the Demon Sealing Clan can use the Demon Sealing Zone, and they are mostly high-ranking demon sealers.

However, Yuan's cultivation level was too weak to be a high-ranking demon sealer, hence why they thought nothing about him— until now.

After capturing the demons, Yuan approached them and spoke in a calm voice, "I'm interested in something. If you answer my question, I will let you out of the Demon Sealing Zone."

"Hmph! As if we will believe you!" The demons sneered.

Yuan ignored their response and began questioning them anyway, "Let's start with an easy one.. How long have you lowly demons been hiding down here?"

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Chapter 850: Hibernation

Chapter 850: Hibernation

"The answer is... go fuck yourself." One of the eight demons cursed out loud in response to Yuan's question.

"..."

Yuan merely shook his head and said, "I will ask you again. How long have you been hiding in this underground city?"

"I might consider answering if you throw one of your friends in here. I'm too hungry to answer your questions, after all." Another demon answered.

"Hahaha! Good one! That's right! We'll answer your questions in exchange for those women behind you! How about a limb per question?"

Yuan sighed at their response.

"We can do this the easy way... or the hard way."

[Swords of Eternal Torment.]

With the snap of his fingers, three golden swords appeared above the demons.

"What the heck is that?" The demons tilted their heads to look at the swords.

"I will not repeat myself." Yuan said to them with a solemn expression on his face.

The demons swallowed nervously.

Although the demons didn't recognize the technique, they instinctively feared it.

"And we will not repeat ourselves! Fuck yo—"

Yuan moved his finger in a downward motion, and before the demon could even finish its sentence, one of the golden swords fell from the sky and stabbed itself right in the center of the demon's chest.

"AAAAAAAAAAAH!"

The demon suddenly roared in a painful voice, startling the other demons.

"Hey! What's wrong?!" The demons immediately knew that something was off. After all, they shouldn't feel pain as demons, yet their buddy that just got struck was definitely screaming in pain, and it appeared to be suffering excruciating pain.

"That technique removes your pain tolerance, so you'll feel pain just like the rest of us." Yuan explained to them the effects of the technique, which only terrified them even more.

Regardless of their rank, demons greatly depend on their insane regenerating ability and lack of ability to feel pain, as these two talents allow demons to become fearless creatures.

However, without even one of these techniques, the demons immediately become a flawed existence.

"PLEASE! GET THIS THING OFF ME! AHHHHHH!" The demon pleaded as blood flowed from its eyes.

However, Yuan merely stood there and silently watched with a nonchalant expression on his face. He clearly couldn't care less about the demon nor the pain it was feeling.

For more, visit: MtNovel.com

After torturing the demon for a few more minutes while ignoring the other demons the entire time, Yuan finally spoke, "My questions, do you feel like answering them now?"

"Millions of years! We have been down here ever since the Demon Sealing Clan defeated the Demon Clan!" The demon with the golden sword stuck between its chest answered.

"Very good."

Yuan removed the golden sword from the demon afterward, and he continued to ask, "So you stayed down here for millions of years without leaving this place even once? How do you stay sane?"

"We hibernate." The demon quickly responded to his question again, and it continued, "We demons can hibernate for tens of thousands of years at once. However, that doesn't mean we can sleep for millions of years without any breaks. When we come out of our hibernation, we will leave this place briefly to hunt for food in the surrounding areas. Once we're full, we will hibernate again."

"Hibernation, huh. If I recall correctly, this is also how you demons increase your strength." Yuan said.

"That's right, but we only resort to that when we cannot acquire enough resources to strengthen ourselves." The demon nodded.

Yuan laughed out loud after hearing its words, and he said in a mocking tone, "The eight of you have hibernated for millions of years, yet this is the level of your strength? Were you Spirit Apprentices before you decided to live here? How pitiful! I guess this is because of your immortality. After all, you can't be immortal and have a fast growth rate, or that would be utterly broken."

The demons gritted their teeth in anger after hearing Yuan's words, but they couldn't rebuke his claims, as it was true. In exchange for their immortality and talents, demons are at the rock bottom when it comes to growth.

For example, if an ordinary human cultivator at the first level Spirit Apprentice wanted to reach the second level, they would need at least a couple of weeks if not months. Meanwhile, demons at the same level would require 10 times the amount of time if not more to achieve the same results.

Of course, this restriction only exists in low-ranking demons like these 8 demons. Higher ranking demons would require much less time, and some of them even outright lack this restriction.

"Anyways, since you have answered my questions, I will now let you out of the Demon Sealing Zone." Yuan suddenly said.

"R- Really?" The demon was in disbelief.

"Yes, but you're not completely free just yet." Yuan said, and he turned to look at Lan Yingying.

"You wanted to test yourself, right? I will let you have this one."

"Are you sure?"

He nodded at her before returning to the demon, "If you can defeat my friend, I will let you live. I also won't interfere with your fight... even if you kill her."

A wide grin appeared on the demon's face after hearing Yuan's words.

"Say no more."

Yuan flicked his sleeves, pulling the demon out of the Demon Sealing Zone.

This demon was at the peak of Spirit Lord while Lan Yingying was only at the first level of Spirit Lord. However, Yuan wasn't feeling worried at all, as he was confident in Lan Yingying's ability.

"Young Master, are you sure this is a good idea...?" Feng Yuxiang, on the other hand, didn't have the same confidence as him.

Although she has seen Lan Yingying fight magical beasts before during their little journey in the Lower Heavens, that was not nearly enough to convince her that Lan Yingying will be okay in this fight.

"She'll be fine. Have some faith in her." Yuan smiled.

"..."

'The Divine Paragon's memories are clearly affecting him. If this occurred a month ago, the Young Master would not have allowed her to be in such a risky situation. However, this is the kind of characteristic that is required to survive in the cultivation world, especially once he traverses the upper heavens.' Feng Yuxiang sighed inwardly.

On one hand, she was relieved that Yuan was finally growing up to be more like a cultivator just like how she always wanted, but on the other hand, she was worried that he might be changing too fast, as it could have negative effects on him..

Chapter 851: False Incense

Lan Yingying calmly approached the demon after it was released from the Demon Sealing Zone.

'I wasn't able to help my parents or my grandparents in the Mystic Realm, but I have grown stronger. If I cannot even deal with a single demon, I am not fit to serve him.' Lan Yingying held a solemn expression on her face.

Her black hair suddenly turned white, and her azure eyes turned pink.

"What kind of magical beast are you? You must be really special if you can transform into a human at that level of cultivation." The demon licked its lips as it glared at Lan Yingying.

"Magical beast? Try Divine Beast." She calmly responded.

"She's a Divine Beast...?"

The demons were surprised to learn that Lan Yingying was actually a Divine Beast.

"Hahaha! What luck! I have never tasted flesh or blood from a Divine Beast before! You'll be my first!" The demon fighting her began laughing out loud.

"I cannot wait!"

The demon suddenly flew at Lan Yingying with its mouth wide open.

"Sacred Fire!"

Lan Yingying lifted her arm and pointed her palm at the incoming demon before shooting a large ball of white flames at it.

Due to its arrogance and confidence in its immortal body, the demon didn't even bother blocking or avoiding the flames and ran straight into it, allowing the flames to consume its body.

"Is this all you've got?! Flames don't work against us demons!"

Despite its whole body being engulfed in flames, the demon did not appear even slightly worried about the flames and continued to rush at Lan Yingying, as it was confident that it could easily regenerate faster than the flames could destroy it.

"Eat this, Bloody—" The demon suddenly halted its movements when it was about to launch an attack on Lan Yingying.

"W-What's happening to my body? Why aren't my injuries recovering?!" The demon looked down at its body with a puzzled face.

"What is this?! What the fuck did you do?!" The demon immediately started trying to put out the white flames burning its body, but its efforts were futile, as the flames continued to slowly destroy the demon's body.

Lan Yingying watched the demon slowly being consumed by her Sacred Fire and said, "My Sacred Fire is of divine attributes, which is really effective against demons. I hope you like it."

"Divine attributes?! Don't fuck with me, you damn beast!" The demon stopped trying to put out the flames and started attacking Lan Yingying, hoping that he'd kill her before the flames completely consumed it.

Even though the demon could not feel any pain from the Sacred Fire, its movements were greatly affected by the injuries on its body, making it incredibly sluggish and easy to dodge for Lan Yingying.

'It's not dying fast enough... I need something stronger.' Lan Yingying thought to herself as she distanced herself from the demon.

"Fiery Lotus!"

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Lan Yingying took a moment to create a beautiful lotus made out of her Sacred Fire before launching it at the demon.

BOOM!

The entire underground shook briefly when the Fiery Lotus exploded in front of the demon. "AAAAAHHHHH!" The demon released one last deafening roar before Lan Yingying's Sacred Flames completely erased it from existence.

After killing the demon, Lan Yingying went to collect its demon core.

'Unbelievable... She actually took care of that demon with relative ease...' Feng Yuxiang thought to herself after witnessing Lan Yingying's prowess.

"Yingying, your Sacred Fire has improved tremendously since I last saw it." Yuan said to her with a smile on his face.

"Thank you, but I am not satisfied. Compared to my grandparents, my Sacred Fire is still too weak. The only reason I won so quickly is because that demon had underestimated my flames." Lan Yingying said.

"Then would you like to fight another demon?" Yuan asked.

Lan Yingying nodded her head without any hesitation.

"Alright, give me a moment."

He turned to look at the seven demons remaining, and they all held a solemn expression on their faces.

"Let's continue with the questioning. Whoever answers my questions will get to fight my friend." He said to them.

"My next question is... What trick did you use to conceal your scent and the hidden passage?"

"..."

The demons hesitated to answer his question.

"I won't ask again." Yuan raised his hand, causing the golden swords to tremble.

"A-A treasure!" One of the demons suddenly said.

"Oh? Tell me about this treasure." Yuan turned to look at this demon that was also a peak Spirit Lord.

"I-It's a treasure that can create realistic illusions and conceals presences to a certain extent. We used it to conceal the hidden passage and erase our presence and smell."

"Where is this treasure now?" Yuan continued asking.

The demon turned to look at a certain house in the city below and pointed to it, "It's in that building."

"Allow me, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang said to him before going down to the city and searching the building with the treasure.

She returned a few minutes later with what appeared to be an incense holder made out of jade.

"Here you go, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang handed him the treasure.

"Oh... So this is the treasure, huh. I wasn't expecting it to have such an appearance."

[False Incense]

[Grade: Ancient]

[Quality: Peak]

[Description: Allows the user to create realistic illusions and conceal presences. Can only have one illusion active at a time.]

"Wow, this is a really useful treasure." Yuan inspected the treasure with a smile on his face before storing it inside his spatial ring.

"Alright, you can fight my friend now."

He turned to look at Lan Yingying, "Whenever you're ready."

"I am ready." She nodded.

Yuan removed the demon from the Demon Sealing Zone a moment later.

Lan Yingying and the demon began fighting each other shortly after.

[Sacred Fire!]

However, as expected, the demon didn't dare to touch her Sacred Fire and dodged it instead.

"You only defeated the previous demon because of its arrogance! I won't make the same mistake!" The demon laughed as it launched a counterattack.

"Bloodshot!"

Hundreds of red projectiles flew at Lan Yingying.

[Sacred Fire!]

Lan Yingying created a wall of fire before her, instantly burning all of the projectiles that touched it.

'Looks like I have to go all out if I want to defeat this demon.' Lan Yingying said to herself before transforming into her beast form.

"Wow... Not only did her strength grow but even her size grew a substantial amount..." Yuan mumbled in a low voice when he stared at Lan Yingying, who was now a massive serpent..

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Chapter 852: Just an Ordinary Demon Sealer

Compared to her size in the Mystic Realm, Lan Yingying's serpent body is now doubled in size, so she was about 100 meters long, and her body was twice as thick.

"Do all Divine Beasts grow this big?" Yuan asked Feng Yuxiang while his attention remained fixated on Lan Yingying.

"Yes, most Divine Beasts have very large frames. If I can transform into my phoenix form, I could easily cover an entire town with just one of my wings."

"An entire town? Now that is something I really want to see..."

After transforming into her serpent form, Lan Yingying began attacking the demon aggressively.

[Sacred Fire!]

Lan Yingying suddenly breathed fire from her mouth, covering a large area.

"Shit!"

The demon was not prepared for Lan Yingying's attack and barely avoided her Sacred Fire.

However, Lan Yingying was not done yet, and she immediately flew at the demon afterward.

When she was close enough, Lan Yingying opened her mouth wide open before slamming it shut on the demon.

Once she caught the demon with her mouth, Lan Yingying released another breath of Sacred Fire, incinerating the demon until it was reduced to nothing but its demon core.

After killing the second demon with seemingly even less effort than the first, Lan Yingying returned to Yuan's side.

"I'm speechless, Yingying. You've really grown so much stronger. I think you can even deal with the rest of these demons by yourself if you wish." Yuan said to her.

"You flatter me, Yuan. I am nothing compared to you." Lan Yingying smiled.

"Well, do you want to fight the other demons too?" He asked a moment later.

Lan Yingying turned to look at the remaining six demons before shaking her head, "Unfortunately, I don't think I can fight a Spirit King yet."

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The demons Lan Yingying fought were both Spirit Lords, but the rest of these demons were all Spirit King.

The difference between Spirit Lord and Spirit King is very vast even if it's just a single level from Peak Spirit Lord to First Level Spirit King.

"That's fine. I won't force you to fight them if you don't want to." Yuan said.

And he turned to look at Feng Yuxiang, "What about you, Feng Feng? Do you want to try fighting one?"

A bittersweet smile appeared on Feng Yuxiang's face as she spoke, "As much as I want to impress the Young Master, I know my own capabilities. I may have a higher cultivator than Yingying, but I do not have the means to

defeat demons at my level. They'll just regenerate any damage I deal to them. And while I do have techniques that can completely obliterate them, I do not have the cultivation to use them."

"I see..."

"Even though we're both Divine Beasts... I'm sorry for being useless..." She sighed.

"Don't think like that. You're not at fault here, and you're definitely not useless. We all have something we can and cannot do." Yuan shook his head.

"Anyways, since this is the case, I guess I should finish this."

Yuan approached the six demons.

"Let's change things up a bit. Instead of fighting my friends, you'll be playing with me now, and to make things fair, I will fight all six of you at once." He said to the demons, dumbfounding them.

"This humiliation—I will definitely make you regret it!" The peak Spirit King demon gritted its teeth in anger, as it had never been treated like a toy before.

And without any hesitation, Yuan walked into the Demon Sealing Zone to be with the rest of the demons.

"Y-You arrogant bastard! Die for me!"

The demons wasted no time attacking him the moment he entered the Demon Sealing Zone.

"Ha!"

After dodging their attacks, Yuan counterattacked with the Empyrean Overlord, slicing one of the demons there in half.

And just as that demon expected to regenerate from its seemingly superficial wound, it realized that the other half of its body had turned into stone.

"Watch out for his sword! Don't let it hit you!" The demon used what little time it had left to warn the others before turning into stone completely.

However, even if they knew that Yuan's sword could seal them, there was very little they could do about it. Due to their enclosed area, there was simply nowhere they could run.

Furthermore, they had to constantly worry about the golden swords above them, as Yuan could use them to strike at any moment.

Many minutes later.

"This guy is playing with us! Just who is this human?!" The demons cried inwardly when they eventually realized that Yuan was going easy on them.

"What's wrong? Why are you stopping? Don't you want to taste my flesh? Drink my blood?" Yuan calmly provoked the demons while being surrounded by them.

"If you want to die so much, let me help you!"

The peak Spirit King demon suddenly exploded with chaotic energy.

However, before it could really do anything, the two golden swords that had been on standby suddenly started moving again.

"AAAAH!"

The demon roared when the golden swords impaled its body.

"This is our chance! We don't have to worry about the golden swords anymore!" The other demons realized this chance and attacked Yuan simultaneously.

Suddenly, the other four demons started screaming in pain as well. "Y-You can summon more than three of these things?!" The demons were shocked to see more golden swords appear since they thought that he was limited to just three.

"Three?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"I don't know how you came to that conclusion but..." He pointed above them.

The demons subconsciously lifted their heads to look, and to their absolute shock, hundreds of golden swords that were not there a moment ago is now there.

"You... Who are you?!" The peak Spirit King demon suddenly shouted out loud.

"I'm just an ordinary demon sealer that happened to come across this place by pure chance." Yuan responded.

He then removed his mask to show the demons his face.

"Y-Y-You..."

The demons' faces immediately drained of all colors when they saw Yuan's face.

No matter how many millions of years have passed, they could never forget the face of their worst nightmare.

"D-Divine Paragon?!"

Chapter 853: Accepting Their Fate

"D-Divine Paragon?! Impossible! It can't be! No human cultivators could possibly live for so long!" The demons were in disbelief after seeing Yuan's familiar face.

After all, tens of millions of years have passed since the Demon Clan was defeated by the Demon Sealing Clan. Even if a cultivator has achieved true immortality, it requires a miracle to live this long without encountering any mishaps, unless they were in seclusion for so long.

"Impossible? Even though I am standing right before you?" Yuan said in a calm voice.

"You're a fake! A mere illusion! You may be able to disguise your appearance, but you can't hide your cultivation and smell! You're too young and weak to be the Divine Paragon!"

"Is that so?"

Yuan suddenly turned to look at Lan Yingying and asked her, "Can I get one of the demon cores?"

Lan Yingying nodded her head and handed him one of the demon cores she just received.

Once the demon core was in his grasp, Yuan opened his mouth and tossed it inside, shocking the demons.

After swallowing the demon core, Yuan opened his mouth to show the demons that he'd really consumed the demon core. "Do you still doubt my identity?" He asked them a moment later. "D- Divine Paragon..."

All five demons fell to their knees after coming to the conclusion that Yuan was truly the Divine Paragon, as there is only one person in the Nine Heavens capable of consuming demon cores.

And once they came to this conclusion, they lost all will to fight. In fact, they could only remain still and tremble in fear.

The demons even subconsciously stopped breathing from fear.

Seeing the condition of these demons, Yuan thought to himself, 'They should be plenty terrified now. This is the best time to kill them. And harvest their demon cores.'

And without hesitation, Yuan suddenly stretched his hand out, stabbing through one of the demon's chest and grabbing its crystal before destroying it.

The demons were well aware that Yuan had just killed one of their companions, but none of them dared to move even a finger and acted like they didn't see it.

In their minds, there was no point resisting before the Divine Paragon. In fact, they might risk offending the Divine Paragon by resisting him, who is famous for torturing demons before consuming their demon cores.

'At least it will be a swift death.'

The demons sighed inwardly and accepted their fate.

They have witnessed the Divine Paragon torture and kill its companions in the middle of an active battlefield before, and they wanted to avoid such a fate at all cost, even if they have to silently lie there and wait for their execution.

'So they're just going to accept their fate, huh?' Yuan realized this as he killed the second demon.

Not including the Divine Paragon's memories, this is his first time seeing demons give up in such a fashion.

Yuan pitied these demons for a brief moment, but then he recalled the scene of demons bathing in the Red Pond and many more terrible things that they have done to humans.

A few moments later, Yuan approached the last demon alive, who was also the strongest demon in the group.

"Before you kill me, can I ask you a question?" The demon suddenly spoke in a low voice.

"What?"

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"Is it true that you wiped out the demons within the Demonic Realm?" The demon lifted its head and stared at Yuan with a profound expression.

"What do you think?" Yuan responded with his own question.

"You're definitely more than capable, but whether you actually killed them... I cannot say for sure."

After a moment of silence, Yuan said, "I don't know."

"You don't know...? Or you don't want to answer?"

"The former." Yuan said.

And without elaborating any further, Yuan finished off the demon.

After killing all of the demons, Yuan collected the demon cores and deactivated the Demon Sealing Zone.

"Good work, Young Master. Those demons trembled before your presence." Feng Yuxiang said to him afterward.

"Thank you, but if I have to be honest, I'm a little disappointed by the results. It didn't feel good killing beings that have no will to fight, even if they are demons." He sighed.

He then turned to look at Lan Yingying and said, "Here, take these."

"Demon cores? Why are you giving them to me?" She asked with a puzzled face.

"I want you to use them to further strengthen yourself," he said.

"Thank you, but I think you need them more than I do. If you consume these demon cores, you'll definitely become a Spirit King." Lan Yingying said.

"That might be true, but I want to become a Spirit King through the Demon Sealing Pagoda, and there is less than a month before I can challenge it again. You know, increasing my companion's prowess is just as important as raising my own."

"Then I won't be humble." Lan Yingying nodded and accepted the demon cores.

"Thank you, Yuan."

"Anyways, with the demons gone, let's scout this place to make sure we don't leave anything useful behind. Who knows, we might find another treasure or two in here." Yuan said a moment later.

And he continued, "I don't sense any other presence beside ours in this place, so it should be safe to split up to make the search quicker."

Feng Yuxiang nodded and said, "I will take the north area."

"Then I will look around the south side." Lan Yingying said.

"I will go west. Whenever you finish with your area, go to the east side and we'll group up there." Yuan said.

"I understand."

Sometime later, they split up and descended into the ruined city.

'This place looks pretty beat up...' Yuan thought to himself as he walked through the street with his divine sense activated, as that was more efficient and convenient than searching house by house.

However, even after many minutes of searching, Yuan was unable to find anything that was remotely useful.

After going through his area twice without finding anything, he started making his way towards the east side of the city..

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Chapter 854: Blood-Soaked Mountain

Lan Yingying and Feng Yuxiang also went to the east side of the city after searching their area with no results.

"Did you guys find anything special? My side was empty." Yuan asked them.

"Nothing, but I'm not surprised. This place hasn't been visited by anyone beside the demons for millions of years. I'd be shocked if anything but spiritual treasures lasted that long."

"Then let's take a quick look at this last area before we leave this place." Yuan said, and they began walking through the east side of the city.

After walking for about ten minutes, Feng Yuxiang suddenly stopped and frowned.

"What's the matter, Feng Feng? Did you find something?" Yuan asked her.

"Not something. Someone. Although faint, I can sense a presence up ahead."

"Someone? Who could it be? I don't smell any demons." Yuan said.

"I think it's a human cultivator."

Yuan frowned and said, "Let's go!"

Feng Yuxiang nodded and picked up her pace, leading the others to this unknown presence.

Once they were close enough to see the person behind this presence with their divine sense, they stopped to analyze the situation.

"A human cultivator. He doesn't seem to be conscious. But what's he doing down here?" Feng Yuxiang said.

"Do you think this person could be that woman's missing son? Maybe the demons captured him and brought him here." Yuan speculated.

"That's possible, but we won't know for sure until we speak with him. Please wait here while I make sure it isn't a trap, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang said.

Yuan nodded and allowed Feng Yuxiang to go first.

Sometime later, Feng Yuxiang approached this man and nudged him with her feet, almost like she was seeing if he was a corpse.

"Hey, wake up."

"Ugh... My head hurts like hell..." The man muttered in a low voice as he sat up and looked at his surroundings.

"Where am I? Who are you?" The man asked Feng Yuxiang a moment later.

"You're currently underground, beneath the Demons' Valley. How did you get here? And who are you?"

"Demons' Valley...?" The man looked puzzled for a moment before snapping out of his daze and jumping to his feet.

"That's right! I remember now! I came to the Demons' Valley with my friends, but just as we were leaving, this group of demons appeared out of the blue and captured us! They ate my friends and even forced me to watch! What happened to the demons?!" The man began panicking after recalling his memories.

"I see... So you're really that woman's missing son. Anyways, we have already dealt with the demons. You don't need to worry about it anymore."

"You dealt with the demons...?" The man stared at her with a dazed face.

"Not me. My Young Master." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Follow me."

Sometime later, Feng Yuxiang returned to Yuan with the man.

"Young Master, this person really turned out to be that woman's missing son. According to him, he was captured by the demons." Feng Yuxiang explained the situation to Yuan.

"Wait... You know my mother?"

Yuan nodded and said, "Yes, we met her on the way here. She was worried sick that you didn't return home in time and stood in front of the Demons' Valley. We agreed to help her find you after hearing her story."

"I see... Thank you very much for coming here and saving my life. I would've been food for those demons if you'd arrived any later. I don't even want to imagine my mother grieving over my death..." The man sighed.

"I wish I can repay this debt, but I have nothing on me."

"Don't worry about it. We didn't do this for any reward." Yuan shook his head.

"Still, I can't just leave without giving you anything..."

The man pondered for a moment before speaking, "Oh! I know!"

"Although I cannot give you anything of value, I can lead you to something of value! You see, after being captured by the demons, I overheard them talking about a treasure that'd recently appeared inside the Blood-Soaked Mountain! I don't know what kind of treasure it is, but they seemed very excited about it."

"A treasure within Blood-Soaked Mountain, huh..." Yuan mumbled in a pondering voice.

"Where is this Blood-Soaked Mountain?" Feng Yuxiang asked.

"I'm not really sure, but it's within the Demons' Valley." The man said.

"I know where it is." Yuan suddenly said. "It's a little far from here, but it's not too bad if we fly straight there."

"If you don't mind, I would like to return to my mother now." The man asked them a moment later.

Yuan nodded, "Go ahead. The exit is over there."

"Once again, thank you for saving my life and sparing my mother from grief." The man bowed to them before leaving.

"Are you sure about this, Young Master? There are still many unanswered questions about his situation and his mother..." Feng Yuxiang asked him after the man left.

"It's fine. I doubt we really need to know these answers, anyway."

"If you say so."

Ding!

<You have completed the Quest: Grieving Mother's Plea>

<Fame +10>

"Are we going to the Blood-Soaked Mountain now?" Feng Yuxiang asked as they left the underground area.

"Yes, I am really interested in this treasure. If we fly straight there, it should only take us half a day to get there."

"I understand."

After leaving the underground area, Yuan and Feng Yuxiang began flying towards the Blood-Soaked Mountain while Lan Yingying transformed back

into a bracelet to rest.

"Truly an impressive lad. I didn't expect him to deal with the demons so quickly and effortlessly. And his growth... It's almost terrifying. Who could've predicted that we would find a monster like him in that small place?"

The man that had been captured by the demons watched Yuan and Feng Yuxiang disappear into the horizon with a profound smile on his face.

Once he could no longer see their figure, the man's appearance began distorting, transforming into a handsome middle-aged man.

"If it's him... Perhaps he can defeat that man..."

The man created a portal and disappeared into it shortly after..

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Chapter 855: Golden Celestial Tree

After flying for half a day, Yuan could finally see the Blood-Soaked Mountain in the distance.

Although it looks like a regular mountain right now, it used to be soaked in blood from the top to bottom.

However, if one looked closely, there were still some red colors left on this mountain.

"So this is Blood-Soaked Mountain... I guess we should split up and look for the treasure." Feng Yuxiang suggested after they arrived.

"Wait." Yuan stopped her.

He closed his eyes and took a couple of deep breaths.

"Okay, I don't smell any demons around here. Let's go look for the treasure." Yuan said a moment later.

Lan Yingying also appeared to help search for the treasure.

Feng Yuxiang and Lan Yingying searched the area surrounding the mountain while Yuan searched the mountain itself.

The peak of the mountain was flat, almost like the Dragon Spiral Mountain, so Yuan went there first.

"This place still reeks of blood even after millions of years..." Yuan sighed as he searched the top of the mountain that was also riddled with skeletons. Sometime later, Lan Yingying's voice resounded in Yuan's head, "Yuan, I

think I found something. I am currently inside the mountain. There is an entrance at the south."

"Okay, I am coming."

Yuan immediately began making his way back down the mountain. At the south end of the mountain, there was a concealed cave that had been kept hidden by these red vines that covered the bottom of the mountain.

"I'm surprised that you found this cave." Yuan said to Lan Yingying after arriving and seeing the situation.

"It actually looked even more concealed before. I had to remove some vines just to get inside," she said.

"What did you find inside?" Feng Yuxiang asked.

"Well... I think it would be better if you see it for yourselves."

"Let's go." Yuan said as he entered the cave.

After following a narrow path, they entered this spacious area inside the mountain.

At the end of this room was a beautiful tree with red leaves growing on a golden trunk, and this tree was growing in the middle of a small pond with glistening golden water.

"Wow... Is this the treasure that the demons mentioned? What do you think, Feng Feng?" Yuan asked Feng Yuxiang, who was the expert when it comes to treasures.

However, Feng Yuxiang didn't respond.

Yuan turned to look at her to see a dumbfounded expression on her face.

"Feng Feng?" He called her again.

"Eh?"

Feng Yuxiang snapped out of her daze and looked at Yuan.

"S-Sorry, Young Master. I was dozing off just now."

"Judging by the look you had, you know what kind of treasure this is?" He asked.

Feng Yuxiang nodded with a serious face.

"Young Master, this treasure is called the Golden Celestial Tree. It's an incredibly rare treasure that requires thousands of years to grow, and judging by the size of this tree, it's millions of years old. This kind of treasure is hard to come by even in the upper heavens."

"Oh... What does it do?"

"All sorts of things. The crimson leaves can be used in alchemy; the golden trunk can be used to create treasures, and the golden liquid can be used to temper one's body."

"Tempering my body? That's perfect!" Yuan said.

Seeing that Yuan was prepared to jump into the water, she quickly said, "W-Wait a moment, Young Master!"

"If you temper your body, your cultivation will, without a doubt, surpass Spirit King and perhaps even Spirit Emperor."

"Oh, if I do that, then I will be forced to ascend, huh? So what do you suggest? Can we store the liquid somewhere?"

Feng Yuxiang nodded, "Yes, I have the perfect treasure for it."

She retrieved a large, transparent gourd a moment later and said, "We can store the liquid in this gourd. It will keep the liquid clean and pure."

"Please." Yuan nodded.

Feng Yuxiang proceeded to collect the water with the gourd, which didn't take too long.

Once that was done, she handed him the gourd and said, "The leaves and trunk will have to be collected separately. However, the leaves will quickly lose spiritual energy if we don't store them properly."

She took out a couple of wooden boxes and said, "We'll store the leaves in these boxes meant for pills. It will prevent the leaves from going bad or losing spiritual energy for one thousand years."

"As for the trunk, it can be stored in any spatial ring."

Yuan nodded, "Let's store the leaves first."

They quickly began removing the crimson leaves from the tree.

After storing the crimson leaves, Yuan yanked the golden trunk from the ground and stored it inside the Dragon Spatial Ring.

"I still can't believe that we'd found a Golden Celestial Tree in this place." Feng Yuxiang sighed afterward.

"How much do you think we'll be able to receive from this treasure if we were to sell it?" Yuan suddenly asked.

"Y-You want to sell the Golden Celestial Tree?" Feng Yuxiang looked at him with wide eyes.

"No, I'm just curious."

Feng Yuxiang then said, "Well, just the leaves alone are worth a few hundred million spirit stones."

"A few hundred million spirit stones?!" Yuan exclaimed.

Feng Yuxiang nodded and said, "And that's the least expensive part from the Golden Celestial Tree."

"The trunk can be sold for a few billion spirit stones while a small bottle of the liquid is worth as much as all of the leaves combined."

Yuan swallowed nervously after realizing the value of the Golden Celestial Tree.

Who would've thought that they would come across such a fortuitous encounter in the Demons' Valley?

"I'm really glad we decided to visit Demons' Valley." Yuan chuckled.

Sometime later, they left the cave after making sure there were no more hidden treasures.

"Now how are we going to find Jia Chong? The Demons' Valley is not a small place. It'll take weeks to cover the place, but we only have a couple of days left before we must meet up with Xiao Hua and Min Li." Yuan asked them for suggestions..

Chapter 856: Jia Chong

"Honestly, I don't think there is anything we can do besides hope for the best." Feng Yuxiang shrugged.

"It's not like we have to find him. I came here mostly because I was curious about the Demons' Valley. If we don't find him in the next few days, we can just leave." Yuan said.

"Okay."

"We should split up to make things faster." Feng Yuxiang suggested.

"Are you sure?" Yuan asked, as he was worried that something might happen to them.

"Young Master, we'll be fine. There are only magical beasts roaming in this place and there are rarely any that fly. If we encounter a demon, we'll notify you immediately."

"If you say so." Yuan nodded.

Thus, Yuan and the others began wandering the Demons' Valley randomly in search of Jia Chong.

Two days later, right as Yuan prepared to log off for breakfast, Feng Yuxiang's voice resounded inside his head, "Young Master, I found him!"

"That's great! Where are you?"

"If you continue flying north for about 200 miles, you will reach us," she said.

"I understand. I will be there as soon as possible."

Yuan logged off the game and notified Chu Liuxiang that he will be missing breakfast today before returning to the game and making his way towards Feng Yuxiang.

A few hours later, Yuan met up with Feng Yuxiang and Lan Yingying, who had arrived shortly before him.

"Where's Jia Chong?" Yuan asked them.

Feng Yuxiang pointed at a certain location on the ground. Yuan followed her direction until he could see an old man wearing rags about a mile away.

"Is it just me or is there something off about him?" Yuan raised his eyebrows after seeing the dazed expression on the old man's face.

"He's giving me the same feeling as the residents at the nameless town." Feng Yuxiang said.

"So he's gone crazy as well?" Yuan frowned slightly.

"Most likely. He probably spent a little too long in the Demons' Valley and got affected by the miasma. Now he's just aimlessly wandering this place."

"Is there anything we can do to help him?" Yuan asked.

"Well... We can try cleansing the miasma from his body, but I won't be able to do it since my flames can only protect people from being affected by the miasma."

Feng Yuxiang turned to look at Lan Yingying and continued, "But perhaps Yingying can do it with her divine attribute Sacred Fire."

"Do you think you can do it?" Yuan asked her.

"I can try."

"Alright, let's go down there and see if he's really lost his mind first."

They descended a moment later and approached Jia Chong from behind.

"Excuse me. Are you okay?" Yuan asked him.

Jia Chong stopped moving and turned around to look at Yuan, still with a dazed look on his face.

"Ooooh... This... This must be fate!" The old man suddenly snapped out of his daze and began staring at Yuan with a profound expression on his face.

"Huh? Fate?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"Yes! I can sense it! Your fate is extremely strong! So strong that even I cannot fathom it! You have the strongest fate out of all my encounters!"

"My name is Jia Chong, a servant of fate! Tell me, what do you desire?"

Yuan looked at Feng Yuxiang and said, "He looks perfectly fine..."

"I don't know. It's almost as though the miasma stopped affecting him after seeing you..." Feng Yuxiang mumbled in a dumbfounded voice.

"Anyways, I am looking for someone that can help me remove Destiny Seals." Yuan said to Jia Chong, acting like he didn't know what Jia Chong was capable of to make it seem like their encounter was purely by chance.

"Destiny Seal, huh? Our encounter must definitely be due to fate." Jia Chong nodded to himself.

"On top of being a servant of fate, I happen to be an Array Master as well. I can help you remove the Destiny Seals if you want."

"Really? You'll do that for me? How much do you need? I will pay for your services."

"No need. I cannot possibly accept money from someone with such a powerful fate."

"Is that so... Then I won't be humble. Thank you, Senior Jia." Yuan immediately began dumping out all of the Gu Family's treasures.

He wasn't worried that Jia Chong might steal his treasures since Jia Chong is only a first level Spirit King and there were three of them.

"There's more treasures than I'd expected..." Jia Chong smiled after seeing the small mountain of treasures before him.

"I won't complain even if you ask for a payment..." Yuan said.

"No, it's fine."

Jia Chong didn't say anything else and took a seat before the treasures.

He then began creating array symbols at a fast pace.

Yuan watched Jia Chong work with intensive focus, making sure to memorize all of the symbols that he'd used and the order he combined them.

It took about two minutes for Jia Chong to remove a Destiny Seal, and after an hour of non-stop work, he'd manage to clean all of the treasures of their Destiny Seal.

"I am finished." Jia Chong said as he wiped the sweat off his forehead.

"Thank you very much, Senior Jia." Yuan bowed to him afterward.

"No need. It was a pleasure to assist you, young man."

"You can call me Yuan."

Jia Chong nodded, "Then Yuan, I have one last thing for you."

He retrieved a scroll and offered it to Yuan.

"What is this?" Yuan raised his eyebrow.

"This is the array combination for removing Destiny Seals. If you learn it, you will be able to remove Destiny Seals yourself."

"A-Are you sure? This is very valuable, right?" Jia Chong nodded and said, "You have already paid the price."

"Eh? How?"

"I have traversed this world in search of someone like you, and after 2,000 years, I have finally found you. You have no idea what this encounter means to me, Yuan." Jia Chong said with a smile..

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Chapter 857 - Medallion of Fate

"Searching for someone like me? Why?" Yuan asked.

Jia Chong didn't immediately respond and instead retrieved a medallion with the word 'Destiny' on it. He then extended his hand and offered it to Yuan.

"What's this?" Yuan accepted the medallion without thinking.

"This is the Medallion of Fate. If you return it to its owners, you will be given a chance to start a new life— or so I am told. Ever since I acquired this medallion, I have invested my life into returning it to the rightful owner, but it appears that my fate isn't powerful enough. However, I'm sure you'll be able to find its owners."

"Or so you're told? So you don't really know the real purpose of this medallion?" Feng Yuxiang asked with raised eyebrows, as she cannot imagine investing her entire life chasing after some rumors.

"I may have no concrete proof, but I believe it truly is the purpose of this medallion. After all, I started being able to see other peoples' fate after acquiring this medallion." Jia Chong said.

"So you can see our fate— our future?" Yuan asked with interest.

"No, my abilities are not strong enough to see your future, but I can tell if someone has a strong fate or not." Jia Chong shook his head.

"..."

Feng Yuxiang wanted to say that it was a load of bullshit, but since Jia Chong helped Yuan with the Destiny Seals, she didn't want to be rude to

him.

Yuan thought to himself, 'Sounds like the Divine Crystal of Heavenly Fortune. It can tell what kind of fate we have, too.'

"Anyways, it is about time I leave and return to my journey. I have lingered around this place for a little too long." Jia Chong suddenly said.

Yuan quickly said, "Once again, thank you for your help and for this array combination."

Jia Chong silently nodded with a smile on his face before flying away.

Yuan looked at the Medallion of Fate with a profound expression on his face.

"Do you really believe that crazy old man? All this nonsense about fate, I don't believe it." Feng Yuxiang said after Jia Chong left.

"I don't know, but I feel some sort of connection with this medallion, like I have seen it before." Yuan said.

"Really? Where?"

He shook his head, "I don't know."

"Anyways, let's meet up with everyone before we reunite with Xiao Hua and Min Li." He said after storing the Medallion of Fate into his spatial ring.

Thus, Yuan began making his way back to the hotel to pick up Meixiu and the others.

That night at dinner, Yuan said to the others, "I just finished my business, so I am heading back to the city. Are you guys prepared for the disciple examination?"

"Yes. I just finished my preparations as well. Those spirit stones you gave us really came in handy." Wang Ming nodded.

"Right? It's actually worth much more than I'd expected. I still have a few thousand left even after going on a shopping spree." Wang Bingbing said.

"Once again, thank you for the spirit stones." Shi Lang said.

"I should arrive at the city by tomorrow night, but if you're already heading to the gathering site, you don't need to wait for us." Yuan said to them.

"Alright."

After dinner, Yuan returned to the game so he could continue returning to the city.

Once he returned to the city the following day, Yuan met up with Meixiu and the others.

"Is this everybody?" Yuan asked Wang Ming, as there were only five people there, including Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang.

"Yes, the others are either already at the gathering site or making their way there." Wang Ming nodded.

"Fortunately, the gathering site isn't too far away. We can get there in about two hours if we use the teleport devices, and the disciple examination won't start until tomorrow morning." Wang Bingbing said.

Yuan nodded and said, "Then let's get some rest tonight and make our way to the gathering site early tomorrow. It wouldn't be a good idea to stay up for the night right before such a big event. You'll need all the energy you can get."

"Alright. Let's meet up at sunrise tomorrow."

Since it's been a while since he's gotten any proper rest, Yuan also decided to get some sleep.

The following morning, Yuan and the others began making their way to the gathering site.

"Hey, Yuan, do you know anything about the examination? Like what we'll be doing?" Shi Lang asked him as they moved.

"No, I don't." He shook his head.

"I heard that you used to be a disciple at the Dragon Essence Temple. What was the disciple examination like over there?" Wang Ming asked.

Yuan proceeded to recall his experience at the Dragon Essence Temple to the others.

"I see... So we should expect something similar, huh?"

"Every sect is different." Yuan said.

"What should we do if we fail the examination?" Shi Lang suddenly asked.

"I'm sure you'll all pass with your talents." Yuan smiled.

"But it's not guaranteed, right?"

"If you're already thinking about failing before even starting, then you're fated to fail." Wang Bingbing shrugged.

"My sister's right, Shi Lang. Don't be so negative."

"W-What? I was just curious... I am not thinking about failing..." He quickly said.

"Yeah, yeah."

Two and a half hours later, Yuan and his group arrived at the gathering site for the Seven Spirit Academies, which was taking place in a massive square that was built specifically for the examination.

"Holy shit, there's got to be at least a hundred thousand people here right now." Wang Ming exclaimed when he saw the sea of people there.

"Is it always this crowded? Won't it take forever to finish the examination at this rate?" Shi Lang sighed.

While the others were surprised by the spectacle there, Yuan looked for Xiao Hua.

Once he sensed her presence, he called for her through their spiritual connection, "Xiao Hua, can you hear me?"

"Brother Yuan!" Xiao Hua immediately responded with excitement.

"We're right outside the square. We'll wait for you here."

"Okay!"

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Chapter 858 - Seven Spirit Academies' Disciple Examination

Chapter 858 - Seven Spirit Academies' Disciple Examination

"Yuan? What are you waiting for?" Wang Ming asked after noticing that he was just standing there.

"I'm waiting for a friend of mine," he said.

Five minutes after Yuan contacted Xiao Hua, two figures could be seen soaring through the sky above the square for the disciple examination.

"Oh, there she is." Yuan looked up and watched as Xiao Hua descended right beside him with Min Li, who looked a little shocked.

"Brother Yuan!" Xiao Hua immediately went to hug him even before her feet touched the ground.

"Once again, sorry for leaving you behind, Xiao Hua." Yuan said with a bittersweet smile.

"Who's that?" Wang Ming asked with raised eyebrows.

"This is Xiao Hua, she's the first friend I made in this world." Yuan introduced her to the others.

"Oooh, how cute!" Wang Bingbing stared at Xiao Hua with glitters in her eyes.

"Anyways, where are the others? The examination should be starting soon." Yuan asked them.

"Who knows. There's too many people here to tell." Shi Lang shrugged.

"We'll probably see them during the examination." Wang Ming said.

Sometime later, Yuan approached Min Li and asked her, "How are you feeling?"

"I'm a little nervous if I have to be honest," she sighed.

"Really? I can tell that your cultivation has improved. You'll do fine."

"Thank you, but I cannot help it. It's been a very long time since I've felt such emotions. And this is the Seven Spirit Academies that we're talking about. I've heard of their reputation even when I was still in the Lower Heavens."

"The acceptance rate is also incredibly low. There will probably be less than ten thousand people who will pass the examination despite the amount of people here today."

"Even then, I still have faith in you." Yuan smiled.

"..."

Min Li began blushing.

Sometime later, everybody at the square stopped talking when seven figures descended from the sky and landed on a platform above the square, and all of them emitted the aura of a Spirit Lord.

"Welcome to the Seven Spirit Academies' Disciple Examination, young cultivators. I am Elder Lang of the Heavenly Academy. Before we begin, allow me to introduce our judges for the examination."

"Elder Mon from the Universal Music Academy... Elder Ging from the Healing Spirit Academy... Elder Yi from the Lonely River Academy..."

After introducing the other six elders that hailed from one of the Seven Spirit Academies, Elder Lang continued, "As you already know, the Seven Spirit Academies have decided to start our disciple examination early due to circumstances. However, this does not mean it will be any easier to join us."

After giving a quick speech about the disciple examination and the history of the Seven Spirit Academies, Elder Lang sat down while another elder stood up.

"I will now speak of the rules for the examination." The elder said.

"First and foremost, there are four sections in the examination you must pass before you qualify to join us. Once you pass all four sections, we, representing the Seven Spirit Academies, will offer you a spot in our sect. Some of you may receive more than one offer while some of you may only receive one offer. If you have been offered to join more than one sect, you are allowed to choose which sect you wish to join."

"If your desired sect did not offer you a spot, do not panic, as it's not impossible to change sects later. As long as you join one of our sects, it is possible to transfer to another sect at a later date. Hell, you can even negotiate with us at the end of the examination if you so choose."

"Now let's talk about the rules for our examination."

"First rule, you are not allowed to deliberately kill other participants. If caught, you will automatically fail the examination and be banned from ever joining us for the rest of your life."

"However, this does not mean you cannot hinder others' progression or fight them. The cultivation path is filled with bumpy roads and uncertainty. You cannot expect it to be a walk in the park."

"Second rule, you are allowed to use any treasure you want as long as it doesn't disturb the examination or cause massive destruction to the area."

"Third rule, you are strictly prohibited from consuming any sort of pills that will enhance your body or spiritual energy. This includes recovery pills. The Seven Spirit Academies are looking for raw talents— people with real potential. Sure, one might argue that allowing the usage of powerful treasure is the opposite of such a statement, but it still requires some skill to control such a treasure, whereas consuming a pill that enhances your strength temporarily doesn't require any skill."

"Final rule... You should already know this, but if you are above the age of 40, you are not qualified to participate in the examination. However, if you still wish to join us, you may visit us at another time for an interview."

The elder took a seat after announcing the last rule, and another elder stood up.

"Let's move onto the examination itself now."

"As you all heard, the examination will have four different sections."

"For the first part of the examination, you will have your talents evaluated. Your spiritual energy, your spiritual veins, your aptitude— everything. Allow me to be completely honest here. Less than 20 percent of you will pass the first examination."

The nervous atmosphere amongst the participants became even heavier after hearing such words.

"For the second examination, we will analyze the extent of your talents."

"For the third examination, you will be given limited time to hunt magical beasts."

"And for the final examination, if you somehow make it this far, you will be interviewed by the seven of us."

"Now, you will be given 15 minutes to prepare yourselves before we open the portals to the real examination area."

The moment the elder sat back down, the participants began mumbling to each other about the examination.

Chapter 859 - Seven Spirit Academies' Disciple Examination (2)

Chapter 859 - Seven Spirit Academies' Disciple Examination (2)

"See, I told you that the examination will be quite similar to the one you took for the Dragon Essence Temple." Wang Ming said to Yuan during their fifteen minute break.

"I guess so." He nodded.

"I think we can expect the same examinations for most sects in Cultivation Online. After all, one's talent and prowess are the most important to cultivators, so it's only natural for them to evaluate us in those aspects." Shi Lang said.

"Anyways, good luck, guys." Yuan said to them sometime later.

Fifteen minutes passed in the blink of an eye.

"The Seven Spirit Academies' Disciple Examination will officially begin now!" Elder Lang stood up and waved his sleeves.

The very next moment, multiple experts appeared and activated their treasures, creating a portal at the front of the square.

"This will lead you to the first examination, where you will be evaluated! There are 20 teleportations, each taking you to a separate area to make things faster. Go!"

The participants there immediately began walking into the portals, disappearing from the square.

Meanwhile, 20 large projections appeared above the square, each displaying a separate area for the first examination.

The square quickly became empty, and within mere minutes, only Yuan, Xiao Hua, Meixiu, and Chu Liuxiang remained.

When Elder Lang saw this, he said, "What are you guys doing? If you don't hurry up, the portals will close, and you will automatically fail the examination."

"Oh, sorry, we're not here to participate. We're here to cheer on our friends." Yuan said.

"If you want to spectate, you're in the wrong place. There's another area for spectators." Elder Lang responded.

"Is that so? If you don't mind, can you tell me where this place is?" Yuan asked.

Elder Lang pointed towards the north and said, "It's quite far from here, so even if you run there now, you won't make it before the examination ends."

"It's fine. Thank you for telling us." Yuan said.

He then looked at Meixiu and the others, "Let's go, shall we? I'll carry you with my spiritual energy."

"Okay."

They nodded.

The seven elders then watched with gawking expressions as Yuan lifted Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang into the air before flying away with them.

Once they were no longer in view, Elder Lang mumbled in a dazed voice, "That young man was a Spirit Grandmaster? How come I couldn't sense his cultivation base?"

Since these elders were all below the third level Spirit Lord, they were unable to sense Yuan's cultivation base even though he wasn't deliberately hiding it.

While Yuan and his group made their way to the spectators' area, Wang Ming and the others waited for their turn inside this massive room that had multiple objects placed around the room.

Of course, these objects were used to evaluate the participants' talents.

After waiting for two hours, it was finally Wang Ming's turn.

"Place your hand on this crystal ball and pour as much spiritual energy as you can into it." The examiner said to him.

Wang Ming nodded and placed his hands on the empty crystal ball.

'Hm? There's something resisting my spiritual energy. Is this part of the exam?' Wang Ming wondered to himself as he poured his spiritual energy into the crystal ball, quickly filling it with glittering smoke that resembled fog.

Although there was something resisting him, it only held him back slightly, and the more the crystal ball filled up with fog, the stronger the resistance became until he could no longer continue.

"A-Amazing..." The examiner mumbled in a dazed voice, and his eyes were glued to the crystal ball.

After snapping out of his daze a few moments later, the examiner said, "Y-You can stop now."

"How did I do?" Wang Ming asked.

"You passed. Here's your token. Make sure you don't lose it." The examiner handed him a red token.

"Hmm? This token is a little different than what the others before me got. Why is that?" Wang Ming noticed this and decided to ask the examiner.

"Because there are three different tokens that can be handed out depending on the participants' result. Those that barely passed will receive a white token, and those that passed with average results will receive a green token.

As for the red token, those are only given to participants with excellent results such as yourself. In other words, they are given to geniuses and those with the highest potential." The examiner explained.

"I see... Thanks, I guess."

"Please go through that portal at the end of the room. You'll be taken directly to the next examination. Once there, show the examiner your token."

"I understand." Wang Ming nodded before leaving the place through the portal.

'What a talented young lad. He'll definitely become a powerful cultivator in the future if nurtured properly.' The examiner thought to himself as the next participant stepped in front of the crystal ball.

"Place your hand on this crystal ball and pour as much spiritual energy as you can into it." The examiner repeated his sentence to Wang Bingbing, who was right behind Wang Ming.

She nodded and placed her hand onto the crystal ball, pouring her spiritual energy into it.

'Wow! Another genius! She's almost on par with the last participant! Two geniuses back to back? What are the chances!' The examiner cried inwardly.

"Here you go. You passed." The examiner handed Wang Bingbing a red token as well.

"What's this? Why is it red?" Wang Bingbing asked out of curiosity.

The examiner smiled and explained everything to her.

"I see... Thanks." Wang Bingbing said before making her way to the next examination.

"Next!"

Once Wang Bingbing left, Shi Lang took her place.

"Place your hand on this crystal ball and pour as much spiritual energy as you can into it." The examiner repeated.

Shi Lang nodded and placed his hand onto the crystal ball.

When the examiner saw the results, he didn't dare to believe his eyes.

'Another genius?! What the fuck?! Where are all these geniuses coming from?!' He exclaimed inwardly.

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**Chapter 860 - Seven Spirit
Academies' Disciple Examination
(3)**

Chapter 860 - Seven Spirit Academies' Disciple Examination (3)

"H-Here's your token. It's red because you've achieved excellent results." The examiner handed Shi Lang his token and explained the purpose of it without being asked.

"I see. Thank you." Shi Lang accepted the token and began making his way towards the portal.

After exiting the portal, Shi Lang found himself standing in front of a massive lake. However, there was something special about this lake.

"The water is silver? What kind of lake is this?" Shi Lang wondered to himself as he approached Wang Bingbing.

"I see that you also received a red token." Wang Ming said with a smile when he noticed Shi Lang's presence behind them.

"Yes. By the way, what is happening here?"

"I'm not too sure, but it appears to be some kind of exercise where you have to walk on the water."

"Walking on water? Sounds like the same examination Yuan took at the Dragon Essence Temple when he had to approach a silver tree."

"Looks like it."

After waiting for another two hours, it was finally Wang Ming's turn.

"You will need at least 40 steps to pass this part of the examination." The examiner said to him.

Wang Ming nodded and took a deep breath before taking his first step into the silver lake.

'Feels like I am walking on something that's liquid yet solid at the same time...' Wang Ming thought to himself as he took his second and third step.

Half a minute later, he was already at the 30th step.

'Is this supposed to be hard?' Wang Ming wondered as he approached the 50th step.

On the 61st step, he finally began feeling some resistance, and it would become increasingly harder to move his leg with every step.

By the 70th step, he was sweating profusely.

"Heavens, he's already taken 75 steps! We have a genius here!" The other participants watched Wang Ming approach his 80th step with admiration in their eyes.

"Ah! I cannot go on!" Wang Ming gave up after taking his 82nd step and collapsed on the water.

One of the examiners there went to pick up Wang Ming before bringing him back to land.

"Congratulations, young man. You currently hold the top score for this examination." The examiner handed Wang Ming another red token before sending him to the next examination.

Wang Bingbing was next.

Two minutes later—

"Wow! 78 steps! That's two high scorers' in a row!" The other participants exclaimed.

"Does anybody know her name? She's such a fairy!"

"No, I don't recognize her."

"Hey, do you think she's an NPC or a Player?"

"Who knows. She kinda gives me a feeling from both sides."

"Huh? What's that supposed to mean?"

"It's hard to explain, but she gives me the feeling of an NPC but also the feeling of a Player as well."

"How's that possible?"

"Don't ask me. It's just a feeling."

After Wang Bingbing received her red token, Shi Lang stepped onto the silver lake and began his test.

Ten steps, twenty steps, thirty steps.

Fifty steps, sixty steps, seventy steps.

"79 steps... 80 steps... 81 steps... 82 steps! He's rivaled the top score!" The participants were ecstatic with the results even though they were not the one achieving such a result.

'D-Damn it! I cannot even lift my legs! Move, damn it! Move!' Shi Lang shouted inwardly as he pushed himself to make that 83rd step.

However, no matter how hard he tried, he was not able to make the step.

After collapsing on the lake, one of the elders there carried him back to the land.

"Congratulations! Here's a red token for your excellent results!" The examiner handed a red token to Shi Lang afterward.

"Thanks..." Shi Lang accepted the token in a dispirited manner.

Noticing this, the examiner asked him out of curiosity, "What's with the long face? You achieved 82 steps, which is the highest score in this examination thus far."

"You mean one of the highest? I wanted to beat him, but alas..." Shi Lang sighed.

"Him? Are you acquainted with the other participant who scored 82?"

"Something like that, I guess."

"Anyways, I am going to head to the next examination."

The examiner nodded and said, "By the way, this examination and the next examination is treated as one examination, so you still have 2 more to go after the next one."

"Is that so? Good to know."

Meanwhile, after flying for four hours straight Yuan and his group finally arrived at the spectators' area, which took place in a massive coliseum.

In the middle of the coliseum was a treasure that projected the disciples' examination in real time, allowing the millions of spectators to enjoy the disciple examination while being far away.

"Are you sure we should be watching them from up here...?" Meixiu asked Yuan as she sat on the Emyrean Overlord above the coliseum with Chu Liuxiang beside her.

"Why not? It's not like we're bothering anyone by spectating up here. And there's too many people down there." He calmly responded.

"If you say so..."

Meixiu looked down and swallowed nervously, as she could sense many gazes on them, which is only natural, as they were sticking out like a sore thumb in the sky.

"Oh! Look at the screen on the far right! That's Wang Ming!" Yuan pointed at one of the projections that was showing Wang Ming during the second examination.

"A silver lake, huh? It sure brings back memories of my disciple examination at the Dragon Essence Temple."

"I see Min Li. She's at the bottom left corner." Meixiu said.

"89 steps, huh? That's the highest score so far."

"Oh! I see Xi Murong and Hong Xiuquan! 81 steps and 83 steps!" Chu Liuxiang said.

"As expected of the Six Spiritual Elites. All of their top geniuses are so close to each other in terms of potential and talent— not including Li Jinxi. She's definitely on another level." Yuan mumbled to himself, feeling a little pity that he couldn't see Li Jinxi's evaluation.

However, just as he had such thoughts, Meixiu pointed at a certain projection and spoke in a puzzled voice, "Hey... That girl on the far right... That's Li Jinxi, right?"

"What? Really? You're right! That's definitely Li Jinxi!" Chu Liuxiang confirmed.

"Huh? What's she doing at the examination? I thought she wasn't going to participate." Yuan muttered in a dazed voice.

Chapter 861 - Li Jinxi's Evaluation

Chapter 861 - Li Jinxi's Evaluation

Li Jinxi, who had suddenly decided to participate in the examination for whatever reason, stepped onto the silver water once it was her turn to be evaluated.

10 steps, 20 steps, 30 steps.

Li Jinxi walked the silver lake without any effort like Wang Ming and the others.

Once she reached 60 steps, the spectators noticed her presence and began focusing more on her.

70 steps... 75 steps.... 80 steps...

The specators and the examiner expected for Li Jinxi to stop soon, but to their absolute shock, she continued walking without any problems, almost as though she was not being restricted by the silver lake.

81 steps, 82 steps, 83 steps.

Li Jinxi quickly passed Hong Xiuquan, who had the highest score amongst the others within their group.

87 steps, 88 steps, 89 steps, 90 steps...

Li Jinxi surpassed Min Li's record shortly after and became the new highest scorer.

However, Li Jinxi's brilliance did not stop there, and she continued to walk the silver water at the same calm and steady pace that she has been since the beginning.

95 steps... 97 steps... 100 steps!

Li Jinxi eventually achieved 100 steps, shocking all spectators that had their eyes fixated on her.

"Heavens! Who is that girl?! At this rate, she'll even surpass Senior Nie's record of 107 steps!" The seven elders were baffled by Li Jinxi's immense talents and mysterious background.

And in their mind, they began pondering what they could offer Li Jinxi to entice her to join their sect!

While the seven elders pondered, Li Jinxi continued to increase her steps.

105 steps, 106 steps, 107 steps!

Li Jinxi has matched Senior Nie's record, becoming the first person in the last five thousand years to achieve such a feat!

'This genius... The Heavenly Academy must have her!' Elder Lang thought to himself as he stared at Li Jinxi's beautiful yet tranquil face.

The other six elders were thinking the same, and despite none of them saying it out loud, they were all fully aware of the others' thoughts.

However, unbeknownst to these elders and the spectators, this was just the beginning of Li Jinxi's dominance.

110 steps, 120 steps, 130 steps!

Li Jinxi's pure dominance for this examination was so shocking that it left all of her spectators completely silenced, and they could only quietly watch her walk the silver lake like a goddess.

Once Li Jinxi reached 150 steps, she finally stopped moving.

When the spectators saw this, they sighed in relief. If Li Jinxi were to continue any further, they might lose consciousness, as they had forgotten how to breathe while watching her.

After stopping, Li Jinxi turned to look at the examiner and spoke out loud, "When do I stop?"

"E-Excuse me?" The examiner didn't comprehend her question at first.

"When do I stop? Or should I continue until I cannot?" Li Jinxi clarified, dumbfounding the examiner and the spectators alike.

The examiner nodded his head in a dazed voice and responded in a shaky voice, "Y-Yes. You continue walking until you cannot move anymore."

"Okay."

And without saying another word, Li Jinxi continued walking.

155 steps, 160 steps, 165 steps.

"Li Jinxi... She's really built differently..." Chu Liuxiang chuckled.

Yuan smiled and said, "I don't want to look down on the Six Spiritual Families, but Li Jinxi was born in the wrong world. If she had been born here instead..."

If Li Jinxi had been born in the real cultivation world, where there are plenty of resources to assist her growth, she would definitely flourish and be much more formidable than currently.

"H-How is this possible?! She's already at 200 steps! I have never seen anything like this before!" Elder Lang exclaimed in a shocked voice.

"I really want to know where this genius— No, this monster came from..."

One of the elders there suddenly retrieved a communication.

When the others noticed this, they immediately realized the reason and also took out their own communication jade slip.

"Sect Master, this is urgent! Hurry and look at—"

"I know. I am already well aware of the young lady at the examination. We must secure this genius for our sect at all cost. In fact, I am heading to the examination site even as we speak. Leave everything to me."

"I understand. Good luck, Sect Master."

The other elders had similar conversations with their Sect Masters.

"I assume that you all just spoke with your sect masters." Elder Lang spoke out loud after everyone finished their conversations.

They all nodded silently.

"Then I will also assume that they all decided to personally recruit her."

Once again, the elders silently nodded.

"I see... For all seven Sect Masters to be involved in a disciple examination, this is truly an unprecedented event. However, it is definitely a justified one."

"Hey, you guys want to make a bet?" Elder Yi suddenly said.

And he continued, "A bet on which sect will acquire that genius."

"Sure, but I will obviously be cheering for my own sect."

"Me too."

"Same here."

"Then it's settled."

Meanwhile...

250 steps... 260 steps... 270 steps...

Li Jinxi was nearing 300 steps, and at the same time, she was approaching the other side of the lake that required 500 steps to reach.

"Do you think she will make it to the other side of the lake?" Meixiu asked out of curiosity.

"Probably." Yuan nodded.

"What makes you think so?"

"The way she's walking... I cannot feel any resistance from it. As for the others, you can tell when they slow down."

"Now that you mention it, she doesn't even have a drop of sweat on her." Meixiu mumbled.

350 steps... 375 steps... 400 steps!

"She's only 100 steps away from the end of the lake! I can't believe my eyes!"

"Do you think she could be cheating with some treasure?"

"That's possible..."

The spectators, especially the other participants there, began suspecting Li Jinxi to be cheating because of her performance that was too ridiculous to believe.

Chapter 862 - Li Jinxi's Evaluation (2)

Chapter 862 - Li Jinxi's Evaluation (2)

"That's it! She must be cheating! After all, 400 steps is simply too ridiculous! It's impossible!"

"Examiner, that participant must be cheating! You need to do something about it!"

The participants in Li Jinxi's examination began complaining to the examiners there, some of them even urging the examiners to stop the examination.

Of course, these examiners were also suspicious of Li Jinxi's performance, but none of them dared to call her a cheater outright. After all, what if Li Jinxi's performance turned out to be real and that she was a monster who could walk 400 steps? They did not dare to risk offending such a genius even if it's the last thing they do.

"Whether she is genuine or not, we do not have the qualifications to make any decisions. The elders overseeing this examination will make those decisions." One of the examiners said to the participants there.

"Wha—?! It's clear that she's cheating! I heard the highest score ever recorded was only 170 steps by the founder of the Heavenly Academy! Are you telling me that some unknown girl nobody recognizes can somehow double that number?! This is utterly ridiculous!"

The examiner's eyebrow twitched upon hearing the participant's words. Indeed, the highest score ever recorded was 170 steps, and Li Jinxi just walked her 410th step. If one thought about it logically, there was no way such a situation could be possible.

However, anything is possible in the cultivation world.

"I will not repeat myself. The elders will make the decisions. If you're not content with my answer, you may leave this examination."

The participants no longer dared to talk back after hearing such words, and they returned to watching Li Jinxi in silence.

Meanwhile, unbeknownst to the spectators and even the examiners there, seven figures suddenly appeared above the area where Li Jinxi was being evaluated.

These seven figures were Sect Masters of the Seven Spirit Academies, and they have all decided to personally oversee Li Jinxi's examination because of her unnatural performance.

"Think she's cheating?" One of them asked out loud.

"I don't sense any treasures on her."

"Me neither."

"I heard from the examiner that did her first evaluation that she managed to make the crystal ball explode by pouring too much spiritual energy into it." One of them suddenly said.

"Just where did such a monster come from? She appears very young as well."

"Just so you all know, this girl will be joining my Universal Music Academy."

"Huh? Did you hit your head on your way here? Her talents will be wasted if we let her join your sect. She doesn't even play the instrument."

"And how do you know that?"

"I can tell by her physique and demeanor. She's definitely the type to use a sword, so she should join my Formless Sword Academy."

"We can debate about this later. For now, let's just watch her."

Sometime later, Li Jinxi made her 450th step.

'Hm?' Li Jinxi's tranquil face slightly changed when she noticed some mysterious power restricting her movements, making it harder for her to move. Of course, it wasn't anything that could cripple her movements, and she could still move with relative ease.

"Looks like she's finally feeling it." Yuan said out loud while most people didn't notice anything different about Li Jinxi.

"Really? She still seems to be walking just fine." Chu Liuxiang said.

"It's not enough to really test her, but she is slowly approaching her limit. Of course, I still believe that she will make it out the lake."

After taking her 460th step, the mysterious force intensified, making it much harder for her to move.

When she tried to take her 476th step, Li Jinxi found it incredibly hard to even lift her leg, almost as though it was chained to an anchor that was already at the bottom of the lake.

"Hmph!"

After taking a deep breath, Li Jinxi released her cultivation, and her eyes turned red.

Furthermore, her body began emitting a bloodthirsty aura that would slowly become visible to the eyes, making it seem as though she was enveloped by a red aura.

"That appearance... Yuan, didn't she also look like that during her first fight with you?" Meixiu asked him.

He nodded, "Yes. However, she looks a bit different now compared to back then, like she has more control over it."

After activating her family's secret technique, Li Jinxi started walking again in her original pace, perhaps a little faster even, almost as though the

mysterious force restraining her had disappeared.

"What kind of technique is she using? She's releasing such a tyrannical aura."

"I don't know, but I can tell that her body is growing increasingly stronger with every passing second."

"It reminds me of the forbidden technique 'Berserker's Bloodlust', which enhances one's body, granting them unrivaled strength at the cost of their sanity and control over their body and mind, turning them into mindless beasts. However, she doesn't appear to have gone mad, so it's probably a different technique."

"Her technique perfectly fits my Indomitable Flesh Academy's teaching, and it even resembles our most powerful cultivation technique! She must join our academy!"

"Bullshit! She'll join my Formless Sword Academy!"

"No, she will join my Universal Music Academy! We may mainly focus on instruments and the Dao of Music, but we also have plenty of experts that can teach other things!"

While the seven Sect Masters argued with each other, Li Jinxi took her 500th and final step, leaving the silver lake and returning to land.

"S-She really did it... She really crossed the lake..."

Pretty much every spectator had their wide eyes on Li Jinxi at this moment, all of them feeling as though they were witnessing the beginning of a new legend.

After crossing the lake, Li Jinxi deactivated her technique and walked around the lake until she returned to the participants and the examiners.

"Why are you looking at me like that? Should I not have left the lake and just walked around until I cannot move anymore?" Li Jinxi asked the examiner with a calm yet questioning face.

"Uhh..." The examiners there were speechless.

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Chapter 863 - Final Examination

"N-No... You have done enough. Here's your token..." The examiner said after snapping out of his daze.

However, just as he was about to hand Li Jinxi her token, the examiner quickly took it back and said, "M-My mistake. I almost gave you the wrong one..."

The examiner took back the white token he was about to give Li Jinxi and handed her the red token instead.

After accepting the token, Li Jinxi began making her way to the next examination.

"Should we introduce ourselves now, or should we wait?" The Sect Masters asked each other.

"Let's wait until after the 3rd examination. I want to see the full extent of her talents."

"I agree. She clearly has heaven-sent talent, but the next examination will test a different aspect of her talents."

Meanwhile, in the third examination area that is still considered the second examination, Wang Ming and the others waited for their turn.

In the middle of the room was a massive crystal suspended in midair that contained an immense amount of spiritual energy.

Once it was Wang Ming's turn, he was told to sit before the crystal and try to absorb as much spiritual energy as he could from the crystal.

Wang Ming closed his eyes and took a deep breath before he started absorbing the spiritual energy.

The spiritual energy in the crystal quickly depleted, but once he absorbed around 65 percent of the spiritual energy, his progress slowed down tremendously.

After absorbing about 70 percent of the crystal's spiritual energy, Wang Ming gave up, as he was unable to store any more spiritual energy in his body.

The moment Wang Ming stopped absorbing the spiritual energy, the crystal immediately began filling back up with spiritual energy until it was completely full again.

"73 percent in about 3 minutes, huh? Very good! Here's your token!" The examiner handed Wang Ming his 3rd red token.

"What kind of test is this?" Wang Ming asked out of curiosity.

"It tests how fast you can absorb spiritual energy, which is basically your cultivation talent." The examiner said.

"What about the previous examination? The one where we had to walk on this lake?"

"That tests your innate talent— your true potential, and it is undoubtedly the most important test in this whole examination."

"I see..."

Wang Bingbing sat in front of the crystal after Wang Ming left for the real 3rd examination.

A few minutes later, Wang Bingbing achieved 75 percent.

"Congratulations. Here is your token." The examiner handed Wang Bingbing a red token.

Shi Lang went next, and he also achieved 73 percent in 3 minutes.

"Seriously? Why am I always achieving the same result as him?" Shi Lang sighed as he went to the next examination.

Meanwhile, Li Jinxi showed up in a separate room and waited for her turn at the crystal.

Many minutes later, Li Jinxi sat before the crystal and began absorbing its spiritual energy.

"W-What the hell is this speed?" The examiner was shocked when he noticed how fast Li Jinxi was emptying the crystal.

And in less than a minute, Li Jinxi managed to absorb all of the spiritual energy from the crystal, leaving the examiner speechless.

'Only 7 people have managed to completely absorb all spiritual energy since the founding of the Seven Spirit Academies! This will make her the 8th person!'

"H-Here is your token..." The examiner handed a red token to Li Jinxi with trembling hands.

"The next examination is where I get to hunt magical beasts, is that correct?" Li Jinxi suddenly asked the examiner.

"Y-Yes, that's correct. In order to pass the 3rd examination, you must hunt magical beasts."

"How powerful are the magical beasts?" She continued to ask.

"Well, they are mostly as powerful as a peak Spirit Apprentice, but there are some as strong as peak Spirit Warriors, and there is even a magical beast with the power of a Spirit Master."

"Hm? Is there something wrong?" The examiner asked Li Jinxi when he noticed the disappointed look on her face.

"The strongest magical beast is only as strong as a Spirit Master...?" She asked.

"Yes." He nodded.

Li Jinxi sighed, and without explaining anything, she made her way to the next examination.

'Did I waste my time by coming here?' She wondered inwardly as she entered the portal to the next examination.

Upon exiting the portal, Li Jinxi found herself in a camp somewhere inside the wilderness with a large group of participants gathered there.

"Welcome to the final examination, and congratulations on making it this far. For this examination, you will need to acquire points by hunting magical beasts, and in order to pass this examination, you will need at least 100 points."

"Not all magical beasts reward the same amount of points, and the stronger the magical beast, the more points you'll receive."

"During this examination, the participants are no longer separated from each other, and you can hinder others' progression. However, keep in mind that you're not allowed to kill other participants."

"Before I send you outside this camp, I will give you all something that will count your points."

The examiner handed a jade slip and continued, "Do you have any questions?"

One of the participants there raised his hand and asked, "Do we have a time limit?"

The examiner nodded, "You have until the disciple examination officially ends in four days."

"If you're too hurt to continue or just want to give up, you can return to the camp and let me or any examiner know."

"Although there are experts scattered around the examination area to lower the casualty rate, you are not completely safe from all danger, so death is still very possible. In fact, there is a 30 percent casualty rate for this part of the examination. You may leave now if you're scared."

After answering all of the participants' questions, the examiner sent them into the wilderness.

The moment Li Jinxi entered the wilderness, she retrieved a large greatsword from her spatial ring and began running around the area hunting magical beasts like a maniac, even interfering with other participants by stealing their prey, which quickly caused an uproar amongst the participants.

Chapter 864 - Seven Sect Masters

"H-Hey! Who the fuck are you?! How dare you steal my prey!"

One of Li Jinxi's many victims cried out loud after getting his magical beast stolen right before his very eyes.

"You're running away now?! Get back here!" The victim tried to catch Li Jinxi when she ran away, but he was unable to catch even her shadow and gave up shortly after.

Not far away, Li Jinxi encountered another participant fighting with a magical beast and also stole those points.

"What the?! How dare you steal from me! Do you know who I am?!"

However, Li Jinxi ignored this participant and continued to hunt magical beasts.

The Sect Masters watching this from the sky were amused by Li Jinxi's actions.

"Do you think she's deliberately hindering the others?" One of them asked out loud.

"I don't think so, but if she is, I cannot think of any reasons why she would do such a thing."

In less than one hour, Li Jinxi managed to acquire enough points for her to complete the examination. However, despite that, she continued to hunt magical beasts.

Somewhere in the wilderness, Wang Ming was fighting a 4th level Spirit Warrior magical beast by himself when a figure leaped out from behind him and killed the magical beast before he could land the last strike.

Wang Ming immediately fumed, "You dare steal my prey?!"

However, he stopped when he saw the face of the perpetrator.

"L-Li Jinxi? What the hell are you doing here?" Wang Ming stared at her with wide eyes.

"If I recall correctly, you said that you didn't want to participate in the examination."

Seeing that it was Wang Ming, Li Jinxi didn't immediately run away like she normally would.

"I heard that you get to fight a lot of powerful magical beasts during this examination, so I came here," she calmly responded.

"Huh? You came here just to fight magical beasts? I expected nothing less from you." Wang Ming shook his head with a bittersweet smile.

And he continued, "Well, I don't really care about your reasons for being here, but can you not take away my points? I'd rather not stay here longer than needed if I can."

"I will think about it." Li Jinxi nodded, and she sped off without giving Wang Ming any chance to respond.

"Damn gorilla woman. All she cares about is fighting." After sighing, Wang Ming traveled the opposite direction of Li Jinxi and went a little further before he started hunting magical beasts again.

Li Jinxi would eventually encounter the other members of the Demon Sealing Faction, and she would steal their prey at least once.

Of course, the others were as surprised as Wang Ming after realizing it was her.

"How long are you going to stay here?" Hong Xiuquan asked her.

"Until I am satisfied," she calmly replied.

"You should leave some magical beasts behind for the other participants. I doubt there are unlimited magical beasts here." Wang Bingbing said to her during their meeting.

"Not my problem," she coldly said before returning to her hunt.

"Why even bother coming here? The magical beasts here cannot compare to the ones you find in the wild. If you're looking for strong magical beasts, you're in the wrong place." Wu Zao said to her.

"I didn't think the magical beasts here were so weak, but since I am already here, I might as well enjoy myself."

"H-Hey! This is the third time you've stolen my kill! Aren't we from the same faction?! Or do you have some sort of grudge against me?!" Xi Murong cried out loud.

Li Jinxi merely shrugged before leaving the scene.

Meanwhile, the Sect Masters began debating whether they should stop Li Jinxi before she kills all of the magical beasts there.

"We should probably stop her before she kills all of the magical beasts, right? She already has enough points for a red token, so there's no point in continuing."

"I agree. We also have more qualifying participants than ever this year. It would be a shame if we run out of magical beasts before they even get a chance to fight one."

"Alright, let's stop her."

The seven Sect Master quickly came to a decision.

Sometime later, they appeared before Li Jinxi like ghosts and surrounded her.

Of course, this startled Li Jinxi, who mistook it for an ambush and prepared herself for battle.

"Wait, we're not here to fight." One of the Sect Masters quickly raised his hands and said.

"We're Sect Masters of the Seven Spirit Academies."

"As much as we'd like to continue watching you dominate the examination, it would be problematic if you kill all of the magical beasts on the first day of the examination."

"Is that so?" Li Jinxi did not argue with these seven Sect Masters since they were much stronger than her.

"Then I will take my leave now. How do I leave this place?"

One of the Sect Masters created a portal and pointed at it.

Li Jinxi did not hesitate and entered the portal.

After entering the portal, Li Jinxi found herself in a large room with seven chairs.

The Sect Masters entered the room after Li Jinxi and took a seat in these chairs.

"This part is normally done by the elders in charge of the examination, but we will take their place for this special occasion."

Meanwhile, the spectators were shocked when they saw the seven Sect Masters' sudden appearance.

"Holy shit! Aren't they the Sect Masters of the Seven Spirit Academies?! I have never seen all seven of them gathered in the same place before!"

"They must have shown up for that genius."

"I'm not surprised in the slightest if you consider the ridiculous talent of that fairy. Hell, I wouldn't be surprised even if their ancestors personally decide to show up."

"Imagine being interviewed by all seven Sect Masters of the Seven Spirit Academies! This is so exciting!"

Inside the interview room.

"Can you introduce yourself for us?"

"Li Jinxi," she calmly responded.

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Chapter 865 - The Sect Masters' Offers

Chapter 865 - The Sect Masters' Offers

After introducing her name, Li Jinxi returned to being silent.

A few moments of awkward silence later, one of the Sect Masters spoke, "Is that it...?"

Li Jinxi nodded.

The Sect Masters were taken aback by her response. Can such a short introduction even be considered one?

"What about your family? Can you tell us a little about your background? They must be a prominent power to give birth to a genius like you."

"It's nothing special. They are only an ordinary cultivation family." Li Jinxi calmly responded. She didn't want to waste her breath talking about her family.

"Ordinary family? There's no need to be humble. Which city are they located in?"

"..." Li Jinxi decided to remain silent.

The Sect Masters looked at each other.

In their mind, the reason Li Jinxi didn't want to talk about her family is most likely due to her mysterious background.

'She must be from a hidden family...'

Li Jinxi suddenly spoke, "Why am I here, being questioned? I thought I had already finished the examination."

"Eh? You don't know? This is the last part of the examination, where we interview you. After the interview, each of us will decide if we want you to join our sect, and you will get to choose from the sect that wants you."

"Oh..." Li Jinxi mumbled in a low voice.

She didn't really pay much attention when the elders explained the examination to the participants, so she didn't know much about it.

"Anyways, let's move on from the introduction and get to the main topic. Can you tell us why you want to join our sect and which sect you hope to join today?"

The Sect Masters narrowed their eyes on Li Jinxi, patiently awaiting for her response.

However, Li Jinxi's response would leave them speechless.

"I don't want to join any sects," she calmly said, shocking the Sect Masters and the spectators alike.

"W-What? Then why did you participate in the disciple examination?" The Sect Master of the Heavenly Academy couldn't help but stand up and ask her.

"I only wanted to fight magical beasts. I came here because I heard that there would be powerful magical beasts here." Li Jinxi revealed the ridiculous reason why she participated in the examination.

"S-So you have no intention of joining any of our sect?" One of the Sect Masters asked for confirmation.

Li Jinxi silently nodded.

The Sect Masters turned to look at each other with perplexed emotions on their faces. They have never been put in such a difficult and embarrassing situation before.

"If you don't mind me asking, do you currently belong to another sect?" The Sect Master of the Heavenly Academy suddenly asked.

"No." Li Jinxi shook her head.

"Is there a particular reason why you're not in a sect?"

"I don't like being bound to one place." Li Jinxi immediately responded.

"I see..."

"Then... If we do not restrict you to the sect and allow you to travel as you please, would you be more willing to join one of our sects?" The Sect Master of the Lonely River Academy asked.

Ji Linxi pondered for a moment before nodding her head, "Maybe."

The Sect Masters smiled inwardly when they realized that there is still a chance to recruit Li Jinxi. Even if she doesn't join their own sect, they need her to join at least one of the Seven Spirit Academies.

After all, if other sects acquire Li Jinxi, it would be disastrous for the Seven Spirit Academies in the future, as their position within Spirit Heaven could be challenged with just Li Jinxi's existence alone.

"Alright. I have decided. We're skipping the interview part. I will now offer you a spot in the Heavenly Academy, and it will not just be any ordinary spot." The Sect Master of the Heavenly Academy spoke.

And he continued, "If you join my sect, I will immediately make you a Prime Disciple, allow you access to all of our techniques without any limitations, give you unlimited resources to assist your cultivation, and much more. If there is something you want that isn't stated, I will make it happen. Of course, you will also retain your freedom, so you can go out of the sect whenever you want and for however long you want."

"My Heavenly Academy is the number one sect in the entirety of Spirit Heaven, so there is almost nothing that we cannot do for you."

The other Sect Masters were shocked speechless by the Sect Master of the Heavenly Academy. They didn't think he would offer so much so quickly. Hell, he might as well offer her the entire Heavenly Academy.

However, as ridiculous as the offer was, this made it almost impossible for the other sects to challenge the Heavenly Academy, who was superior in terms of techniques, prowess, and wealth.

After a moment of silence, another Sect Master raised his hand and said, "My Formless Sword Academy will offer you the same deal! You use the sword, right? Although we're not as wealthy and powerful as the Heavenly Academy, our sect has the most Swordmasters and sword techniques in all of Spirit Heaven. Join us and we'll nurture you into the greatest Swordmaster this world has ever seen."

The other Sect Masters also gave Li Jinxi an offer shortly after. While none of them could match the Heavenly Academy's offer, they had to try.

"Do you think she will join them?" Chu Liuxiang suddenly asked.

"Who knows. Li Jinxi is an eccentric woman. I can never tell what she's thinking." Yuan chuckled.

"I don't think she'll join them." Meixiu said.

"What makes you think so?" Yuan asked.

"It's just a feeling."

Meanwhile, back at Li Jinxi's location, many minutes passed in complete silence while the Sect Masters patiently waited for her response.

Eventually, Li Jinxi opened her mouth and said, "Thank you all for the generous offer, but I must decline."

The Sect Masters sighed inwardly after hearing her response.

"May I hear your reasoning?" The Heavenly Academy's Sect Master asked.

Li Jinxi nodded and said, "I have a goal that I really want to achieve. If I could achieve my goal by joining your sect, then I would do so without hesitation, but I do not believe your sects will help me achieve my goal. Therefore, I will have to decline."

"What is your goal?"

Li Jinxi took a deep breath before responding, "There is a person I want to surpass."

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Chapter 866 - Escalating Situation

"Someone you want to surpass? With your talents, there isn't anyone in this realm that can possibly match you..." Sect Master of the Heavenly Academy said.

Li Jinxi sighed after hearing such words, "That confirms nobody here can help me achieve my goal. If you really think I am currently the most talented to walk this land, then you have no idea what's truly out there."

"Forget it. I have already made my decision. I won't be joining any of the sects here. Let me leave this place now."

The Sect Masters exchanged frowned looks with each other.

If Li Jinxi refuses to join them, she could become a huge threat to them in the future, and that future wouldn't be very far away either— not with her ridiculous talents.

Suddenly, one of the Sect Masters there suddenly stood up and scoffed, "Enough of this bullshit."

"Sect Master Sun... You..."

"Shut up!"

The Sect Master of the Universal Music Academy, Sun Hao, shouted.

He then pointed at Li Jinxi and continued, "Who do you think you are, huh?"

"I don't care which family you came from or how talented you are, but how dare you come here and mock us— the Seven Spirit Academies?!"

"How dare you come here and participate in our examination and then tell us that you had no intentions of joining from the start?! I have never been mocked in such a manner before!"

The other Sect Masters remained silent after hearing Sun Hao's words, mostly because it made a lot of sense.

The only reason Li Jinxi can be so relaxed right now is because of her talents that these Sect Masters covet. If it were anybody else, they would've probably been punished with death by now.

However, now that it was clear to them that Li Jinxi does not plan on joining their sect, it would be for the best if they got rid of her so that nobody else could have her.

"Yuan... This doesn't look good..." Meixiu turned to look at him with a worried look on her face.

He nodded, "I know."

After a moment of silence, he said, "Meixiu, Lulu, the both of you stay here. Xiao Hua, we're going back."

"What are you going to do? As much as I hate to say this, Li Jinxi is half responsible for her situation. She could've worded herself better..." Chu Liuxiang said.

"I know she's in the wrong, but I can't just stand here and do nothing. I will, at the very least, make sure that she's safe. We can deal with the specifics afterward."

After putting down Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang, Yuan flew back to the square with Xiao Hua following beside him.

Since he was in a hurry, he flew at his highest possible speed, which was multiple times faster than before, and it would only be a matter of time before he returned to the square with the seven elders.

Meanwhile, the situation between Li Jinxi and the Sect Masters only got worse.

"Say something! Did you purposefully come here just to piss us off or what? I don't care how talented you are— if you are not our ally, then I will deal with you accordingly!"

The Sect Master of the Universal Music Academy released his cultivation, overwhelming Li Jinxi with the intense pressure of a Spirit King.

"!!!"

Li Jinxi's body suddenly lowered until she was nearly on her knees, but she managed to react in time and barely prevented her knees from touching the floor.

The Sect Masters were shocked to see a third level Spirit Master resist the aura of a Spirit King, regardless of their talents. However, this only further convinced them that Li Jinxi is a threat that must be removed if she refuses to be on their side. If you want to read more chapters, visit panda-novel.com

"Sect Master Sun, calm down a bit. Regardless of her actions, she is still a junior, and we are being watched by millions of people right now." The Heavenly Academy's Sect Master said to Sun Hao using spiritual sense.

"Hmph, I wouldn't care even if we're being watched by the whole world. This junior needs to be taught a lesson for looking down on her seniors. Also, it would be dangerous to let an untamed monster like her wander this world. Heaven knows what she is capable of in the future." Sun Hao said.

"I know. Let's give her one more chance to join us before we decide on anything."

"Fine." Sun Hao stopped pressuring Li Jinxi the next moment.

"Haaa.... Haaa..." Li Jinxi breathed heavily with her body soaked in sweat.

Even though she had to resist Sun Hao's pressure for a few moments, it was enough to drain almost all of her energy.

'These people are strong! Much stronger than Yuan when I first fought him!' She cried inwardly.

However, despite her body and instincts trembling in fear, her heart was actually burning with excitement.

'These people... I want to fight them!'

"Do not be mistaken. This does not mean that I have forgiven you for your sins." Sun Hao said, snapping Li Jinxi out of her daze.

Li Jinxi coldly snorted, "If you're expecting me to apologize for my actions, it won't happen."

"Y-You disrespectful little bit—"

Before Sun Hao could release his anger, the Sect Master of the Heavenly Academy stepped forward and said, "What you did here today not only disrespected our Seven Spirit Academies, but it also mocked us, who came all the way out here to invite you to join our sect."

"So you're here to specifically recruit me?" Li Jinxi suddenly asked.

"Yes, that's right. We, the Sect Masters, do not normally intervene in disciple examinations."

Hearing such words, Li Jinxi could only snort coldly, "Really? But I don't recall asking for any of your presence. You came here on your own accord, and now you're blaming me for wasting your time?"

"T-This bitch has zero respect for us! She may be talented, but she's clearly brainless!" Sun Hao gritted his teeth in anger.

Chapter 867 - Death Note

"Young child, I will give you one last chance. If you join us, we will forget about this incident and make you the strongest cultivator in Spirit Heaven. However, if you refuse, then I— and the others here no longer have any reason to continue protecting you." The Sect Master of the Heavenly Academy said to Li Jinxi, offering her a final chance to join their sects.

"I refuse." Li Jinxi immediately rejected his offer, and it was done so in a manner that did not have even the slightest bit of hesitation.

The Sect Master trembled slightly from anger, but he quickly regained control over his emotions.

"Is that so... How regrettable. A talent of your level... We might never see it again." The Sect Master then sat down and closed his eyes.

"You may do as you please, Sect Master Sun."

"I have been waiting for this." Sun Hao immediately released his cultivation base again, instantly flattening the chair behind him.

However, this pressure was not as strong as before, so Li Jinxi was able to endure it without feeling helpless.

'He's going easy on me?' Li Jinxi wondered inwardly.

Sun Hao suddenly retrieved a beautiful zither and said, "Don't worry, I won't kill you so quickly. Disrespectful juniors like you need to be taught a proper lesson."

He then pulled a single string on the zither, creating a beautiful yet crisp noise that echoed in the room.

Hearing this music note, Li Jinxi subconsciously retrieved her greatsword and placed it in front of her, and she could feel something collide with her sword the very next instant, sending her flying backwards.

Li Jinxi proceeded to fly straight out of the building and into this empty and spacious area.

Sun Hao calmly walked outside and said, "If you can resist 3 of my strikes, I will let you live. How about it?"

"Does that last hit count?" Li Jinxi asked.

Sun Hao smiled and said, "You want to be a smartass as well? I too can play that game. And no, it doesn't count, since I only talked about it after releasing that strike, so you still need to block three more."

"Very well. I'll accept your challenge." Li Jinxi nodded.

Sun Hao didn't say anything else and took a sitting position, but he did not sit on the floor. Instead, he hovered in the air with the zither on his lap.

The other Sect Masters also came outside to spectate their challenge.

"Then here comes my first strike."

After taking a deep breath, Sun Hao began playing the zither.

Li Jinxi immediately prepared herself for the attack, but nothing happened even many moments later, and only music came from Sun Hao's zither. Furthermore, it was a very pleasant-sounding music.

'This music... What is this nauseating feeling?' Li Jinxi quickly realized that she could barely stand straight after listening to this music.

"First note— Note of Destruction."

Ting!

A very distinct and clear noise suddenly resounded, snapping Li Jinxi out of her daze.

BANG!

Li Jinxi suddenly felt something incredibly powerful struck her greatsword, which sent her flying back for another 50 meters before she finally touched the floor and began rolling like a metal can.

However, she quickly stood back up with minor injuries.

"Not bad." Sun Hao chuckled.

"Then I will now begin my second strike."

Sun Hao did not stop playing his zither this entire time, so music continued to fill the area.

'Shit... This music... It's making me lose consciousness...' Li Jinxi had to bite her lips until it bled just to keep herself conscious.

"Second note— Note of Annihilation."

TING!

Li Jinxi could feel an immense amount of spiritual energy flying towards her direction, and it was definitely enough to be fatal to even someone like her, but she couldn't avoid it.

"HAAAAA!" Li Jinxi suddenly roared, and her body became enveloped by a crimson aura that reeked with bloodlust.

Li Jinxi could feel all of the muscles in her body being strengthened past their limits, making her feel more confident blocking the incoming attack.

However, when the attack finally struck her greatsword, it not only knocked Li Jinxi a hundred meters away, but it also shattered her greatsword into hundreds of pieces.

Fortunately for Li Jinxi, the greatsword shattered after absorbing most of Sun Hao's attack, saving her life by a hair's width.

However, this also meant that Li Jinxi would not have a weapon to defend against the next strike.

"If you don't have another weapon, you can use your body." Sun Hao said with a cold grin on his face.

"..."

Li Jinxi looked down at her own body to see that it was covered in cuts from the previous attack, and her entire body was soaked in her own blood.

'I might die today...' She mumbled inwardly, yet she wasn't feeling afraid of death even in the slightest.

Meanwhile, outside the square with the seven elders.

"Do you think Sect Master Sun's really going to kill someone as talented as her?"

"If he's convinced that there's no chance to recruit her."

"Well... Do you think he's convinced?"

After a moment of silence, Elder Mon from the Universal Music Academy said, "Definitely."

"Haaa... What a pity."

Suddenly, the seven elders stopped talking and turned to face north when they sensed two unfathomable presence approaching their direction.

"Who's that?! What a powerful pressure!"

The elders were shocked.

"Hm? Isn't that..."

Once these two figures were close enough for the elders to see their faces, it shocked the elders even more.

"T-That's the kid from earlier today! Why is he coming back here?"

A few moments later, Yuan and Xiao Hua stopped in front of the seven elders.

"Take me to that place." Yuan pointed at the projection showing Li Jinxi and the Sect Masters.

"Huh?" The elders showed puzzled looks on their faces.

"That girl is my friend, and I would like to stop them before things get out of hand." Yuan gave them a brief explanation.

"Your friend? Unfortunately, your friend just offended the Seven Spirit Academies and of all people, their Sect Masters. She's going to die, and there's nothing you can do to stop it." Elder Mon sneered.

Yuan narrowed his eyes and said, "I don't recall asking for your commentary."

"Little bastard... I can see why you're that woman's friend... You both lack respect towards your seniors!" Elder Mon roared at him.

However, Yuan wasn't even paying attention to the elder. He was focused on the projection with Li Jinxi, as she'd just successfully blocked Sun Hao's 2nd attack, but it was clear that she would not be able to block the next one.

"Xiao Hua..." Yuan mumbled in a low voice.

Xiao Hua did not need to hear anything else from Yuan to understand his intentions, and she released her cultivation base.

"S-Spirit King!" The elders immediately recognized Xiao Hua's pressure that was even stronger than their Sect Masters' aura.

Yuan approached these elders and stared at them with immense killing intent in his gaze.

"If you do not let me help my friend, I will trample the Seven Spirit Academies until there is nothing left."

"..."

The elders trembled in fear before Yuan's killing intent. Although his killing intent is already plenty strong in the real world, it was on another level in Cultivation Online, and it was definitely more than enough to terrify the souls out of these Spirit Lord elders.

"I-I will open the portal to that place for you!"

The Heavenly Academy's elder was the first one to break, and he immediately created a portal for Yuan.

"Thanks." Yuan didn't say anything else and flew right into the portal with Xiao Hua following him from behind.

Meanwhile, Li Jinxi was prepared to block the final attack even if she had to use her own body.

"He's really going to kill her with his last strike... Are you sure this is the right choice?" Some of the Sect Masters there were still hesitant to let a genius like Li Jinxi perish under such a situation, especially the Healing Spirit Academy's Sect Master.

"If she is not our ally then she can only be our enemy. And I doubt she will change her mind after all of this is done. Might as well get rid of her before she could harm us." The Sect Master of the Heavenly Academy sighed.

The other Sect Masters didn't say anything else and watched as Sun Hao prepared to release his final strike.

"If you can survive this last strike, I will not only forgive you, I will even do anything you want."

A massive grin appeared on Sun Hao's face as he pulled the strings on the zither in a chaotic rhythm.

"Final note— Death Note!"

Sun Hao released the attack with the strength of a Spirit King behind it.

There was simply no way for Li Jinxi to survive this attack, and she instinctively knew this the moment she felt the spiritual energy of the attack.

'Damn it... ' Li Jinxi sighed inwardly as the attack reached in front of her body.

[Heaven Severing Zither Arts!]

Suddenly, another zither note resounded in the area, and before anyone there could react, this zither note collided with Sun Hao's zither note, instantly destroying it.

"W-Who goes there?!" Sun Hao exclaimed in a shocked voice after witnessing what just happened.

Two figures appeared before Li Jinxi the very next moment, standing between Li Jinxi and the Sect Masters, and one of them was holding onto a beautiful black zither in his grasp.

"Y-Yuan...? What are you doing here?" Li Jinxi mumbled in a low voice.

She knew it was him even without seeing his face, as she could recognize him just from looking at his back.

"I'm here to save you, obviously," he said with a calm smile on his face.

Chapter 868 - Persuading the Sect Masters

"Who the hell are you, and how did you get in here?" Sun Hao asked Yuan with a frown on his face.

'He not only blocked my most powerful zither note, but he did so as a Spirit Lord...'

Sun Hao and the other Sect Masters were wary of Yuan's presence.

"My identity isn't of any importance, and I came here by asking those elders at the square." Yuan said.

He didn't want to give them his identity since he was being watched by millions of people right now. Of course, it didn't really matter if his identity is exposed to the Players watching, but he'd rather avoid it if possible.

"You bastard... There's no way they'd let you in here of their own free will... If you have harmed even a hair of their body, I will make you regret it!" Sun Hao growled.

"Don't worry, I didn't touch them. Though, I did threaten them a little, but that was inevitable, as I wouldn't have been able to come here if I didn't." Yuan shrugged.

"So... What do you hope to achieve by coming here?" The Sect Master of the Heavenly Academy suddenly spoke out loud.

"I am here to persuade you all to forgive my friend. No doubt, she was wrong for coming here without any intentions of joining your sects, and she was a little rude, but I don't think that warrants a death sentence."

"So you don't think that mocking the Sect Masters of the Seven Spirit Academies—the most powerful sects in this realm—should be punished with death?" Sun Hao asked.

"Of course not. That's simply unreasonable. If you think that's punishable by death, then should I just kill all of you for trying to kill my friend, which is an even bigger offense in my eyes?" Yuan narrowed his eyes at the Sect Masters.

"Arrogant little bastard. I can see why you're friends. In fact, I wouldn't be shocked if you were a couple." Hao Sun gritted his teeth in anger.

"Do you really think you can kill the seven of us? You're just a mere Spirit Lord." The Heavenly Academy's Sect Master couldn't help but laugh out loud after hearing Yuan's outrageous claims.

Suddenly, a voice resounded inside his head, "Sect Master Li, don't underestimate them! That little girl beside him is a Spirit King!"

Elder Lang had just warned the Sect Master of the Heavenly Academy about Xiao Hua's prowess.

"I see... The reason you're acting so arrogant is because of that little girl beside you, right? However, even if she's a Spirit King, there is only one of her while there are seven of us." Sect Master Li smiled.

"Hm? Xiao Hua? No, I never planned on letting her fight for me. Although she is also more than enough to handle all seven of you by herself, I don't want to trouble her with my problem."

"If you came here to piss us off even more, then you're doing a great job. However, if you're here to help your friend, then you should have never come here." The Sect Master of the Formless Sword Academy said.

"Then how about this? I will fight the seven of you. If I win, you will let my friend go and forget everything that happened between us today. If any of you manage to beat me... I will give you this."

Yuan retrieved a box before showing the contents inside to the Sect Masters.

Inside this box was a bunch of beautiful crimson leaves, but none of the Sect Masters recognized it— except one.

"Leaves from a Golden Celestial Tree! And judging from the intense scent... It's at least a hundred thousand years old!" The Sect Master of the Healing Spirit Academy exclaimed after she picked up its unique scent.

Although the other Sect Masters still aren't aware of its value, they could somehow take an educated guess from the shaken look on her face.

'I have never seen her this shocked before... Those crimson leaves must be extremely valuable...' Sect Master Li thought to himself.

"There are 21 blades of crimson leaves in this box. Do we have a deal?" Yuan suddenly asked them.

"We have a deal!" The Healing Spirit Academy's Sect Master immediately responded without any hesitation, taking the others by surprise.

"S-Sect Master Xiahou! How can you agree to fighting him without even asking for our approval? I don't agree to—"

However, before the Sect Master could even finish his sentence, Sect Master Xiahou interrupted, "With those 21 leaves, I can concoct 7 Golden Aptitude Pills for the seven of us. Do I need to further elaborate the meaning behind those words?"

"G-Golden Aptitude Pills?! And seven of them?! Are you sure about this, Sect Master Xiahou?!" Sect Master Li asked her, seemingly in disbelief.

The other Sect Masters also appeared to be filled with shock at this moment.

"What's a Golden Aptitude Pill?" Yuan turned to ask Xiao Hua.

"It's an extremely valuable pill that can boost one's innate talent up to 50 percent depending on the quality of the pill, and it requires the leaves from a Golden Celestial Tree to create such pills. When did you acquire such a treasure, Brother Yuan?" She asked him after explaining about the pill.

"Ah, we found it within the Demons' Valley right before coming here. In fact, we have the entire Golden Celestial Tree." Yuan said with a smile on his face.

"T-The whole thing?" Xiao Hua was dumbfounded to learn such information, as she was aware of the Golden Celestial Tree's true value.

Meanwhile, the seven Sect Masters finished their conversation.

"Okay, we agree to play your little game." Sect Master Li said out loud.

"Great." Yuan nodded.

"Since I am already in the mood, I shall go first." Sun Hao said.

"You're going to fight me one by one? I had planned on fighting all seven of you at once, though." Yuan said in a nonchalant voice.

The Sect Masters were left speechless by such baffling arrogance behind Yuan's words.

Chapter 869 - Fighting the Sect Masters

"You wanted to fight all of us at once?" Sect Master Li mumbled in a dazed voice.

"I have had enough of your arrogant bullshit! Die!" Sun Hao could no longer endure his anger, as he was mocked by not just one junior but two juniors in a single day.

"Note of Annihilation!"

Sun Hao began playing the zither, creating a powerful zither note that had about 70 percent of his power into it.

In response, Yuan also started playing the zither.

[Heaven Severing Zither Arts!]

Yuan's zither note collided with Sun Hao's zither note once again.

However, instead of just canceling each other out like previously, Yuan's zither note overpowered Sun Hao's zither note and continued to fly at Sun Hao even after destroying his zither note.

"Scatter!"

Sun Hao hastily swept his fingers across all strings on his zither, creating this chaotic sound and barely defending himself against Yuan's zither note.

'This brat... has some ability!' He gritted his teeth from frustration.

The other Sect Masters also realized that Yuan wasn't just all talk from that exchange alone.

'Two cultivation geniuses... How did it come to this...?' Sect Master Li frowned inwardly, as he was beginning to regret their decisions that ended up offending not one, but two cultivation geniuses.

"DON'T UNDERESTIMATE ME, BRAT!" Sun Hao suddenly roared, and his aura skyrocketed as he pulled all of the strings on his zither in an aggressive manner.

"Note of Nine Hells!"

An immense amount of spiritual energy that threatened to destroy everything it touched flew toward Yuan's direction.

Yuan didn't even blink at the incoming attack and used Heaven Severing Zither Arts once again.

"Impossible!" Sun Hao's eyes widened with shock when Yuan's zither note severed his most powerful zither note with seemingly zero effort.

Yuan's zither note continued to fly at Sun Hao after destroying his zither note, and before anyone could react, the zither note severed Sun Hao's left arm from his body.

"Ah!" Sun Hao tumbled to the ground after losing his arm, and the strings on his zither even snapped.

"Sect Master Sun!" The other Sect Masters quickly went to stand between Yuan and Sun Hao.

"You injured my friend, and you even tried to kill her, so I returned the debt by taking your arm. That's fair, right?"

"Y-You bastard... How dare you..." Sun Hao gritted his teeth in anger. Now that he's lost an arm, it would be near impossible to play the zither with the same agility and stability as before. Hell, he might even have to give up the zither.

"Sect Master Sun, here. Quickly eat this." Sect Master Xiahou handed him a recovery pill that immediately stopped his bleeding and even closed up his wound within seconds.

"Do you feel like fighting me at once now?" Yuan asked them after giving them some time to breathe.

The Sect Masters narrowed their eyes at him.

"I will handle this."

The Sect Master of the Formless Sword Academy suddenly stepped forward with a majestic green sword in his grasp.

"My name is Bai Enjue, Sect Master of the Formless Sword Academy. I hereby challenge you to a life or death challenge." Bai Enjue introduced himself as he pointed his sword at Yuan.

"Sect Master Bai?! What are you doing?!" The other Sect Masters were shocked by his words.

"Don't say anything. This is my decision."

Seeing this, Yuan also retrieved his sword and summoned the Empyrean Overlord.

'A Soul Weapon? He can wield both a sword and a zither?' Bai Enjue was inwardly shocked to see Yuan suddenly pull out a huge ass sword. The other Sect Masters felt the same after seeing the Empyrean Overlord.

After snapping out of his daze, Bai Enjue made his move first.

"Formless Sword Art— Formless Edge!"

A blue arc of light followed Bai Enjue's sword as it flew toward Yuan's neck.

After taking a split second to analyze the attack, Yuan also released his own attack. However, it was not a technique. Instead, Yuan just swung his sword

ordinarily while using his Sword Aura to support it.

'He can use Sword Aura?!' Bai Enjue was shocked inwardly when he felt an exceedingly sharp aura coming from Yuan's sword.

The two attacks collided the very next second.

Yuan would be pushed back a couple of steps from the exchange, but Bai Enjue was sent flying backwards.

"Impossible! Even Sect Master Bai cannot match him using a sword?!"

"He can already use Sword Aura at such a young age...?"

The other Sect Masters were beginning to wonder if they'd offended an existence that they shouldn't have provoked.

Meanwhile, at the Heavenly Academy.

"E-Elder Nie! We have an emergency!" A disciple rushed into his room without knocking.

"What happened?" Senior Nie asked with a slight frown on his annoyed face.

"T-The Sect Masters! They are..." The disciple didn't know how to explain the situation without making it sound too bad.

"Hurry up and speak! What happened to the Sect Masters?!" Senior Nie raised his voice.

"T-They are being beaten by some stranger!"

"What? How is that even possible?" Senior Nie immediately doubted this information.

"I-It's true! Watch the disciple examination broadcast!"

Senior Nie didn't say anything else and retrieved a treasure that allowed him to spectate the disciple examination.

After changing the scene multiple times, he finally halted at a specific broadcast where all seven Sect Masters of the Seven Spirit Academies' was gathered, and they appeared to be in trouble.

"What happened to Sect Master Sun?! Why is he missing an arm? And most importantly, why is 'he' there?!?" Senior Nie exclaimed after seeing Sun Hao's condition and Yuan's familiar face.

"T-This is what happened..."

The disciple proceeded to explain the whole situation to Senior Nie, who was speechless by the end of it.

"Fuck! This is disastrous!" Senior Nie was so dumbfounded by the situation that he couldn't even think properly.

'Out of everyone in this world, they had to pick a fight with him?! These idiots!'

'Damn it! I need to stop them before things really get out of hand!'

"Tell everybody in the sect to standby!" After giving the disciple this warning, Senior Nie rushed outside and disappeared from the sect.

Meanwhile, the other six sects had already gathered many experts and started making their way towards the examination area to assist their Sect Masters that were clearly in trouble.

Chapter 870: You Know Him?

"Don't think you've won yet! I am just getting started!" Bai Enjue shouted as he got back to his feet and closed their distance again.

"You're also not the only one who can use Sword Aura!"

Bai Enjue swung his sword that carried Sword Aura this time. However, it was clear that his Sword Aura was nowhere near as powerful and refined as Yuan's Sword Aura.

Yuan didn't say anything and proceeded to block all of Bai Enjue's attacks with ease.

"What should we do? At this rate, our reputation will..."

"Is there even anything we can do at this point? If we attack him at once, that would be akin to admitting our defeat—that we cannot defeat him by ourselves."

"Who here thinks they can defeat him?"

The Sect Masters talked amongst themselves as Yuan and Bai Enjue fought each other.

"Regardless if we defeat him or not today, our reputation has already suffered irreparable damage." Sect Master Li sighed in a dispirited manner.

"So you're saying we should just gang up on him and finish this?" One of them asked.

Sect Master Li narrowed his eyes at Yuan, who was casually fighting Bai Enjue, even looking like he was fooling around.

"I'm not so sure that we would be able to defeat him even if all seven of us fought him together."

"What?! Are you seriously saying that?"

Sect Master Li nodded with a serious expression, "This person must be the one she wants to surpass. His abilities are truly incomprehensible and unfathomable."

"However, as the Sect Masters of the Seven Spirit Academies, we cannot simply run away in such a situation, or we would become laughingstocks. Even if we lose our faces, we must take him down."

The other Sect Masters silently nodded their heads.

Bang!

"Ah!"

Bai Enjue suddenly screamed, causing the other Sect Masters to turn their heads.

"Sect Master Bai! Are you okay?!" Sect Master Xaihou shouted in a concerned voice after seeing the blood flowing from his mouth.

"Y-Yes... This is nothing..." He said in a mumbling voice.

The Sect Masters suddenly approached them and surrounded Yuan.

"Oh?" Yuan stopped his movements and looked at the Sect Masters around him with a calm expression on his face.

"I told you guys to fight me together at the beginning, but you didn't want to listen. Now it looks like I am bullying you guys." Yuan smiled at their frowning faces. If you want to read more chapters, visit pa-nda-novel.c.o,m

"Are you really a Spirit Lord? Or are you hiding your real cultivation?" Sect Master Li suddenly asked him.

"Of course this is my real cultivation. I don't even know how to hide my cultivation." Yuan casually shrugged.

"Then let me ask you another question... Why are you doing this? I don't believe that you came all the way here just to save your friend. You actually came here with the intentions to fight us, didn't you?"

"I will be lying if I say that I am not enjoying our fight. However, I am not that bored to come here just to fight. I truly came here with the intentions to save my friend, but I got a little angry when I saw the state of my friend, so I wanted to punish you all a little."

"If you want, we can stop this nonsense right now. Of course, that means you will forfeit the challenge and forgive my friend."

Sect Master Li snorted and said, "This is no longer about the challenge. You came here and made a mockery out of us. Our reputation took a massive hit because of you and your friend. When someone slaps you in the face, it is only natural you kill them."

Yuan sighed, "Is that so? What a pity."

He suddenly lifted his sword and pointed it at them, "Don't worry, I won't kill any of you, but expect to lose a limb or two today."

The Sect Masters didn't say anything and took out their weapons and treasures.

"Kill him!" Sect Master Li suddenly shouted in a resolved voice.

"HALT!"

A deafening voice suddenly resounded, immediately stopping their movements.

"This voice... Senior Nie?" Sect Master Li recognized his voice the moment he heard it.

Indeed, it was Senior Nie, and he could be seen coming out of a portal with an exhausted look on his face.

"Enough of this! All of you! Stop!"

Without any hesitation, Senior Nie walked right past the Sect Masters and stood beside Yuan.

"What are you doing, Senior Nie?" Sun Hao asked him.

"I am trying to stop this farce before someone actually dies. What do you think will happen to the Seven Spirit Academies if multiple Sect Masters suddenly die?"

"You actually think we'll lose to that brat, Senior Nie?"

"It's not about losing or winning. If you continue to fight him, one or more of you will certainly die. Even if you manage to defeat him in the end, it will be at the cost of some of your lives, and that is not worth it." Senior Nie said.

And he turned to look at Yuan with a perplexed face, as he wasn't sure what to say to Yuan at this moment.

Before Senior Nie could say anything, Yuan smiled and said, "I am not an unreasonable person. If they agree to stop, I won't pursue this matter any longer."

"Thank you, Yuan." Senior Nie nodded.

"W-Wait... Senior Nie... You know him?" Sect Master Xiahou stared at him with her eyes wide as saucers.

"Of course." Senior Nie nodded, and he continued, "In fact, I met him not long ago when I went down to the Lower Heavens to oversee the Mystic Realm. Do you remember that genius I mentioned about after I returned? The one who refused to join us? That's him."

The Sect Masters there stared at Yuan with baffled faces after realizing Yuan's identity, but none of them wanted to believe it.

'He's that prodigy who was rumored to have opened the Mystic Pagoda?!?!'
Sect Master Li cried inwardly.

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Chapter 871: Monster

The place fell completely silent once Senior Nie revealed Yuan's identity to the Sect Masters.

Since none of the Sect Masters were directly involved in the Mystic Realm, none of them recognized Yuan. However, they were definitely intrigued by his existence, as he was able to open the Mystic Pagoda that had been sealed for countless years.

They also didn't think that they would be meeting him anytime soon, as it hasn't been that long since the Mystic Realm ended.

After many moments of silence, Sun Hao spoke, "I'm sorry, Senior Nie, but I won't be able to back down—I can't. I simply can't forgive him, who severed my arm. He must pay for it!"

Bai Enjue then said, "I also won't stop now. I don't have any grudges against him, but I cannot put down my sword after fighting him— my pride won't allow it."

Senior Nie sighed after hearing their words, but he didn't continue to persuade them.

Although Senior Nie isn't a Sect Master, he has been part of the Heavenly Academy even before the current Sect Master, and his reputation and authority within the sect isn't any less than Sect Master Li.

In fact, most people within the Seven Spirit Academies see Senior Nie as a retired Sect Master despite having never taken up that position.

"What about the rest of you? I won't tell you to not fight him, but I highly discourage it." Senior Nie turned to look at the others.

"I am out." Sect Master Xiahou said out loud before taking a few steps back.

As the Sect Master of the Healing Spirit Academy, she specializes in alchemy more than actual combat, and she didn't want to risk her life for something so pointless.

"I will fight," said the Sect Master of the Lonely River Academy, as he was very close with Formless Sword Academy's Sect Master. He would be filled with guilt if he didn't assist Bai Enjue.

With half of the Sect Masters willing to fight, two more Sect Masters also agreed to continue their fight.

Sect Master Li from the Heavenly Academy is now the only person that hasn't come to a decision.

Senior Nie narrowed his eyes at Sect Master Li.

"As the leading sect, it would be shameful of me to back down when the majority of the alliance has agreed to fight," said Sect Master Li with a resolute face.

Senior Nie sighed.

He then turned to look at Yuan with an apologetic look on his face, "I'm sorry. I tried."

"It's fine. I was expecting it." Yuan said.

"Y-You were?"

"Yes." He smiled.

"Anyways, you should stand back. Things will get a little chaotic from here on out."

Before leaving, Senior Nie said to him, "I know I have no right to ask this of you, but... can you spare their lives at the very least? If you kill any of

them, the Seven Spirit Academies will do everything in their power to destroy you."

"I won't make any promises. If they're too weak, I might accidentally kill them, after all." Yuan said.

Senior Nie could only sigh inwardly after hearing such words, and he retreated from the battlefield with Sect Master Xiahou.

"Since you're down one, I will let you attack first." Yuan said to the six Sect Masters with a provoking smile on his face.

"Che!"

Sun Hao snickered in disdain right before retrieving a flute. He then used Qi Manifestation to hold the flute before his mouth, allowing him to play it with just a single hand.

'So he can play multiple instruments, huh?'

If you want to read more chapters, visit pa-nda-novel.c.o.m. When Yuan heard the music, it made him feel a little nauseated. However, the technique was meant to knock out Yuan, and when Sun Hao saw this, he immediately changed songs.

A moment later, the other five Sect Masters surrounded Yuan while feeling like their overall prowess had increased from listening to the music.

"Formless Sword Art— Formless Edge!" Bai Enjue was the first to attack Yuan, initiating a relentless assault that would not stop for many minutes.

"Strength Enhancing Array!" The Sect Master of the Golden Array Academy further enhanced the others' strength before trying to slow down Yuan with restraining arrays.

However, Yuan would easily break out of these arrays.

'This guy! He knows all of my arrays' weaknesses! Is he also an Array Master?'

Meanwhile, Sect Master Li would occasionally throw powerful techniques at Yuan whenever one of the other Sect Masters finished their attack in order to keep up the pressure.

Of course, Yuan easily dodges all of these attacks with his movement technique.

"Fiery Lion Fist!"

The Sect Master of the Steel Lion Academy used his bare hands to attack Yuan from behind.

"Ha!"

Yuan immediately turned around in a kicking motion, blocking the fist attack with nothing but his bare legs.

'What a ridiculously sturdy body! Not even mountains can compare to this guy's body! He must have soaked in countless treasures to acquire such a refined physique!' The Sect Master of the Steel Lion Academy was shocked after their clash. He was someone that would often claim to have the strongest and sturdiest body in Spirit Heaven, but after clashing with Yuan, he began to doubt his own strength.

The six Sect Masters relentlessly attacked Yuan for many minutes without giving him any time to breathe, each using their own talents to assist the others. Their cooperation with each other was perfect, but despite that, none of them have been able to land a solid hit on Yuan, as he was easily blocking and dodging everything they sent his way.

'This is fucking impossible! He has an answer for all of our attacks, and there are six of us attacking him at once!' Sect Master Li cried inwardly, his body soaked in cold sweat.

'What a monster...'

The other Sect Masters also noticed this, but they did not dare to stop attacking Yuan, fearing his retaliation.

Meanwhile, Li Jinxi and the others watched Yuan fight with six Spirit Kings simultaneously while having a lower cultivation.

"He's even smiling..." Li Jinxi mumbled in a voice of disbelief as she stared at Yuan's face that was filled with excitement and joy.

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Chapter 872: Heavens Favorite

Chapter 872: Heaven's Favorite

'So this is the prowess of the man who opened the Mystic Pagoda... He was only a Spirit Master at that time, too...' Senior Nie thought to himself as he watched Yuan play with the six Sect Masters.

Because the Mystic Realm did not show Yuan's movement and actions, nobody but those that were with him knew his potential. This included Senior Nie, who could only imagine Yuan's prowess until today.

"This is absurd... almost comically so..." Sect Master Xiahou suddenly uttered in a dazed voice.

"How can someone like him exist in this world? Why are the heavens allowing this to happen...?"

Hearing her words, Senior Nie responded without looking away from the fight, "This is the heavens' way of messing with us cultivators for wanting to defy them by seeking eternal life. They will occasionally create geniuses that will surpass everyone with ease just to make the others fume with jealousy."

"Of course, if they're feeling extremely bored, they will very, very rarely give birth to monsters that will dominate an entire era, and these monsters are fated to do just that, so there is nothing we can do about it."

"We can beat them, oppress them, mock them, torture them, and even try to kill them, but they will always somehow manage to survive and continue their path of dominance. We call these monsters 'Heaven's Favorite'."

"So you're saying that he's Heaven's Favorite?" Sect Master Xiahou asked.

"I hope so." Senior Nie said with a bittersweet smile on his face.

"Why?" Sect Master Xiahou raised her eyebrows in a puzzled manner.

"Because there actually exists an existence that surpasses even Heaven's Favorite. This kind of existence are independent souls that do not obey any rules— not even those made by the mighty heavens, nor are they affected by fate, so they can essentially do whatever they want while ignoring all rules of this universe."

"There isn't an official name for this kind of existence, but if I have to give them one, I would call them Forbidden Souls, as they are souls that should not be allowed to exist— for the sake of this world and everyone in it."

Sect Master Xiahou was left speechless by Senior Nie's words, and she wondered if Yuan could be this kind of existence.

Meanwhile, Yuan's battle with the six Sect Masters only got more heated with every passing moment, as the Sect Masters were beginning to get desperate.

Most of them had been unconsciously using non-lethal techniques because they were ganging up on a young man that also has a lower cultivation base than them, but the Sect Masters eventually came to a realization— that Yuan isn't human, so they shouldn't fight like they were fighting a fellow human cultivator.

"This bastard is clearly not human! And we won't defeat him until we stop considering him as a human! We need to treat this fight like we're fighting a magical beast— No, a Divine Beast! Let's stop holding back and fight with the intention to kill!" Sun Hao suddenly said to the other Sect Masters.

Although they were hesitant at first, it did not take long for them to agree with Sun Hao.

Once the Sect Masters stopped seeing Yuan as a human, their attacks immediately became more aggressive and destructive.

"Hahaha! This is so fun! That's right! Fight me with the intention to kill me! Fight like your life depends on it!" Yuan laughed out loud as he also

increased his pace and strength.

"Formless Blade— Formless Death!" Bai Enjue used his most powerful technique on Yuan.

The other Sect Masters followed.

"Ancient Lion's Fury!"

"Array of Four Elements!"

"Heavenly Destruction!"

All of the Sect Masters suddenly released their most powerful and destructive technique on Yuan simultaneously.

A massive explosion occurred shortly afterward, forcing the Sect Masters and even the spectators to retreat.

"Y-Yuan..." Li Jinxi swallowed nervously.

'Surely, he couldn't have survived that attack just now... right...?'

While everyone there had their eyes focused on Yuan's direction, Senior Nie decided to focus on Xiao Hua instead for some reason.

'She's not acting, nor does she seem worried even in the slightest...' Senior Nie sighed inwardly after realizing why Xiao Hua remained so calm.

'It's over. The Sect Masters are not capable of defeating this monster...'

Once the smoke disappeared enough, Yuan's figure appeared before the Sect Masters again, and he seemed to be completely unharmed, which left the Sect Masters completely baffled.

After coming out of the smoke, Yuan cracked his fingers and said in a chilling voice, "I would like to believe that I have given you all enough time for your head start. It's now my turn to go on the offensive."

Yuan's words immediately snapped the Sect Masters back to reality.

"Shit! Stop him!" Sect Master Li shouted in a panicked voice.

However, before anyone there could even do anything, Yuan's eyes changed colors, turning into majestic gold.

[Dragon's Gaze!]

All six Sect Masters halted their movements the moment they stared into Yuan's glowing eyes.

"W-Where am I?! Where did the others go?!"

The Sect Masters suddenly found themselves alone in the void, where there was only darkness and this unfathomable presence that continuously grew more terrifying until it was strong enough to shake the very core of their souls.

Once their fear was at its peak, the Sect Masters finally realized what was causing this terrifying presence. However, this entity was so massive that just one of its eyes could make them look like ants before a watermelon in comparison.

"H-Help! I give up! Please! Get me out of here, mother!" Sun Hao was so shaken by the massive eye that he started crying for his mother.

The other Sect Masters had similar reactions.

Bai Enjue dropped his sword and kowtowed before the entity in the void without uttering a single word.

Sect Master Li and the others also did something similar. They had lost all will to fight and offered their unworthy lives to this unfathomable entity in the void!

Chapter 873 - Don't Look

"W-What happened? Why are they just standing there?" Sect Master Xiahou mumbled in a dumbfounded voice as she stared at the Sect Masters with her eyes as wide as saucers. Because Yuan had his back facing her direction, she was unable to see his glowing eyes and understand the situation.

Sect Master Xiahou decided to take a closer look with her divine sense, but Elder Nie suddenly exclaimed, "Don't look!"

"Huh?" Sect Master Xiahou subconsciously retrieved her divine sense from surprise and turned to look at him, only to see a terrified expression on his face.

"Senior Nie? What's wrong?" She asked him in a nervous voice.

"Whatever you do, don't look at his eyes right now. You'll regret it like I am now." He said with sweat dripping down his forehead.

Even though Yuan's Dragon's Gaze wasn't directed towards him, it was still emitting an aura strong enough to shake Senior Nie's soul when he glanced at it with his divine sense.

"What a terrifying technique! It must be at least divine rank!"

Meanwhile, Yuan merely stood there with a calm expression as he watched the Sect Masters stand there with blank looks on their faces, looking like they were in a trance.

If he wanted to defeat the Sect Masters, right now would be the best time. However, he didn't attack them and actually waited for them to break out of his technique by themselves, which is definitely a crueler punishment.

When Senior Nie realized what Yuan was doing, he immediately said, "Y-Yuan! Please have mercy! Their souls will crumble at this rate! That is a fate worse than death!"

Yuan smiled and said, "Don't worry, they won't receive any permanent damages. I am holding back, after all."

'He's holding back?! Even though it's already this powerful?!' Senior Nie cried inwardly.

After standing around for a couple more minutes, Yuan finally decided to act.

However, the Sect Masters remained dazed even after Yuan deactivated his Dragon's Gaze.

"It's time to wake up!" Yuan slightly twisted his body before swinging his fist at Sect Master Li's face, hitting him square in the cheeks.

A cracking noise resounded as Sect Master Li's jaw cracked from the impact. He then flew into the air with his body spinning in an impressive manner.

After sending Sect Master Li flying, Yuan immediately moved to his next victim, sending Bai Enjue flying with a fist to the face as well.

He then sent the Sect Master of the Golden Array Academy, the Sect Master of the Steel Lion Academy, and the Sect Master of the Lonely River Academy flying with a kick in their stomach, breaking some of their ribs in the process.

It was just Sun Hao, Sect Master of the Universal Music Academy left, and Yuan had something special for him.

After slapping Sun Hao in the face to wake him up from his daze, Yuan would batter him with over a dozen strikes, ruthlessly hitting him in the face and body until his entire face was deformed with bruises.

Once all of the Sect Masters were lying on the ground and groaning in pain, Yuan took a deep breath, and said, "I am going to end your punishment here and spare your lives, but if you try to harm me or my friends again, I will not hesitate to come back and claim your lives."

He turned to look at Senior Nie and continued, "Do you have anything to say?"

A bittersweet smile appeared on Senior Nie's face as he spoke, "Just one thing. Thank you for sparing their lives."

Yuan nodded, "I should also apologize for escalating the situation even though I came here with the intention to stop it, especially since there are millions of people watching this..."

"Oh, you don't have to worry about the spectators. We stopped broadcasting this place after your fight with Sect Master Sun, so everything that happened afterward is only between us." Senior Nie said.

"What?!" Sect Master Xiahou turned to look at Senior Nie with a shocked face.

"Why didn't you say so earlier?! I don't know about Sect Master Sun, but the others wouldn't have fought if they knew about that! They fought because they thought that their reputation was at stake!"

"Ehh... Well... We can talk about that after you heal them..." Senior Nie said in an awkward voice.

"Oh right!"

Sect Master Xiahou then fed the other Sect Masters recovery pills and other expensive medicine, healing all of their injuries within moments except the damage done to their pride and mind.

"S-Senior Nie... Are you serious? About the broadcast..." Sect Master Li asked him afterward.

"Yes, it's true. The only people that could see the broadcast are people with direct access to them like me. However, Sect Master Sun's fight with Yuan is public knowledge."

Everybody turned to look at Sun Hao, who had a very bitter look on his face, but there was nothing they could do about it.

"Hey, can we leave now?" Yuan suddenly approached them and asked.

The Sect Masters subconsciously took a step back when Yuan got too close.

"You want to leave after beating us? Are you serious?" Bai Enjue frowned.

"What? Do you want me to take responsibility or something? Except for him, you're all unharmed." Yuan said while pointing to Sun Hao.

"Just so you know, hundreds of thousands of disciples from the Seven Spirit Academies are currently waiting for you outside. If we don't stop them, they will all attack you." Sect Master Li said.

"Is that so..." Yuan began pondering for a moment before showing a cold smile, "Or I can just kill them all."

"You bastard..." The Sect Masters glared at Yuan with killing intent.

Yuan chuckled, "I'm just joking, but if you leave me no choice... That joke might become a reality."

"Also, if you're worried that I might cause trouble for you in the future, then you don't have to worry, as I will be ascending to the next realm very soon."

"What? You're ascending again so soon?" Senior Nie looked at him with wide eyes.

Chapter 874 - Come With Me

"I would like to stay around for a little longer, but it will only hinder my growth." Yuan said with a bittersweet smile.

"Anyways, since I will be leaving this realm soon, you can simply just forget about me. I'm sure you'll eventually forget about me sooner or later even if I don't mention it."

After a moment of silence, Bai Enjue spoke up, "Even if you're gone, what about her? What if she seeks revenge in the future? We cannot take that risk."

Yuan chuckled at his words, "No way. She won't do something like that."

"And we're supposed to just take your words for it?"

"How about this then?"

Yuan turned to look at Li Jinxi before asking her, "Hey, want to come with me? We'll ascend together. The fact you came to this place for entertainment must mean that you're already bored of this realm. I can't say that I'm surprised though. You're really strong, after all."

Li Jinxi's eyes widened slightly after hearing Yuan's suggestion.

"You... want me to follow you?"

"Yes. I can guarantee you that there will be plenty of stronger magical beasts for you to fight up there. You'll be able to fight to your heart's content."

Li Jinxi silently stared at Yuan for a few moments before nodding her head, "Okay, I will go with you."

"Then it's decided."

Yuan returned to looking at the Sect Masters and continued, "As you all just heard, she will be ascending with me. There should be no problems now, right?"

"Do you really think—" Sun Hao opened his mouth to speak.

However, Yuan quickly interrupted, "You should really think twice before you finish that sentence, Sect Master. I have been holding back long enough. If you continue testing my limits, I will stop being so nice."

Seeing Yuan's serious and cold glare, Sun Hao swallowed nervously and forgot what he was going to say.

'He's serious! If we continue to push our luck, he might really slaughter his way out of here!' Sect Master Li cried inwardly.

If Yuan could easily handle all of them at once and with ease, he had no doubt that Yuan would also be capable of dealing with the disciples waiting for him outside.

'A Sect Master can easily be replaced since there is only one person for that role, but if a large population of disciples suddenly dies at once, it would deal almost irreversible damage to a sect that would take hundreds if not thousands of years to fix!'

"Alright, we'll forget about today's incident." Sect Master Li said out loud.

"W-What?! You can't be serious!" Sun Hao snapped to look at him with a shocked face.

"If you want your disciples to die a pointless death, you're more than welcome to do so. However, I will not let my disciples be part of it even if it's the last thing I do!"

"I just told my disciples to return to the sect." Sect Master Xiahou suddenly stepped forward and announced while showing Yuan the communication jade slip.

"The disciples of the Heavenly Academy never left the sect, so we should have any disciples here." Senior Nie said to Sect Master Li, who nodded his head in approval.

"I'll also call my guys off..." The other Sect Masters eventually gave up.

In the end, only Sun Hao remained indecisive. *The source of this content is freewebnovel.com*

"What is this nonsense?! I thought we're supposed to help each other! That is the purpose of our alliance that has stood for thousands of years!" Sun Hao yelled at the other Sect Masters.

"How dare you bring up such bullshit after we risked our lives to fight him with you, Sect Master Sun? You should know better than that!" Sect Master Li immediately roared back.

"Sect Master Sun, while we are obligated to help each other during times of need, it does not mean we must sacrifice ourselves to do so." Sect Master Xiahou said.

"Sect Master Sun, you need some rest, as you're clearly not thinking straight right now." Bai Enjue sighed.

When the rest of the Sect Masters rebuked Sun Hao's stubbornness, it infuriated him. However, there was nothing he could do. He knew that there was nothing he could do against Yuan by himself.

In the end, Sun Hao raised his white flag and commanded his disciples to return to their sect.

"I'm leaving!" Sun Hao also left the place immediately after, as he didn't want to stay in that place for another second.

"We'll contact you again later for a proper meeting, Sect Master Sun." Sect Master Li said to him right before he entered the portal and disappeared from the place.

"It should be clear outside now." Senior Nie created a portal and said to Yuan.

"Let's leave now, shall we?" Yuan turned to ask Li Jinxi, who nodded in a dazed manner.

Yuan proceeded to leave the place with Li Jinxi and Xiao Hua following behind him.

"Senior Nie, tell us everything you know about him." Sect Master Li said in a serious voice after they left.

"I don't mind, but I also don't really know much about them. However, there is one thing that I can say for sure."

"What's that?"

"He's from an extraordinary background with connections to some very powerful people. Do you remember the Flood Dragon's Scale that I recently purchased? The owner and seller of that scale called him 'Young Master'."

"What?!"

The Sect Masters there were shocked to learn this information.

"You said that he came from the Lower Heavens, right? How can he possibly have such connections? Unless he's actually from the upper heavens but purposefully traveled to the Lower Heavens, that's impossible. However, why would he do such a thing?" Bai Enjue said.

Senior Nie shook his head, "The more talented they are, the less we understand them. It'll be for the best if we don't question it and just accept things as they are."

"The bigger question now is... What should we do after all this? I'm also worried about Sect Master Sun. He suffered the most today, after all." Sect Master Xiahou sighed.

"We can talk about that later. For now, we need to return to our own sects and explain the situation to our disciples." Sect Master Li said.

The Sect Masters agreed, and they all left the scene shortly after.

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Chapter 875 - seven Spirit Academies' Disciple Examination's Results

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Sometime after Yuan and Li Jinxi left the disciple examination, they went to meet back up with Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang.

"Sorry for the trouble, Yuan." Li Jinxi apologized to him as they journeyed.

"Don't even mention it. It's only natural that I help my friends out when they're in trouble," he said.

Li Jinxi nodded, and she continued, "By the way, I already knew this, but you're really strong in Cultivation Online. I want to spar with you later when we get the chance."

"Sure." He nodded.

"Brother Yuan." Xiao Hua suddenly approached him.

"What's the matter?"

"Brother Yuan, you seem a little different than usual today. Are you feeling unwell?" She asked him in a worried voice, as she was unaware of Yuan's situation with the Divine Paragon.

"Yes, I am feeling perfectly fine."

Sometime later.

"Yuan! Jinxi! Are you two okay? What happened? The broadcast suddenly stopped, so we couldn't see what transpired after you cut off that man's hand." Chu Liuxiang immediately asked.

"Nothing much. I had a fight with them and managed to convince them to forgive and forget about everything that happened today." Yuan said with a smile.

"Really? Even though you severed that man's arm?"

"It took some effort, but yes, they won't cause us anymore trouble."

"That's good to hear."

"What are we going to do now?" Meixiu then asked.

"The examination is still ongoing, so we'll continue watching until everyone we know has passed."

"Do you think it's a good idea to let them join the sect after everything that has happened?" Chu Liuxiang suddenly asked.

"It should be fine. After all, they don't know about our associations with each other. And even if they did, I doubt they would bother the others just because of our association."

"If you say so..."

Thus, Yuan and the others continued to spectate the examination.

Even though the disciple examination was scheduled to last for a couple of days, it did not mean the participants had to wait until the very end to finish their examination.

After getting enough points to pass from the third examination, the participants may immediately head to the final part of the examination and be interviewed by the Seven Spirit Academies.

Of course, the interviewers were only of elder status.

Therefore, after a couple more hours, Wang Ming and the others passed their examination with top results.

Wang Ming had managed to receive offers from all seven academies to become their disciple, which isn't surprising with his results that ranked top 10. In the end, Wang Ming chose the Formless Sword Academy that specializes in sword art.

Wang Bingbing also received offers from all seven academies, but she joined the Heavenly Academy.

Shi Lang received offers from all seven academies, and he joined the Lonely River Academy, as they had enough spear experts to peak his interest.

Hong Xiuquan decided to join the Steel Lion Academy that specializes in tempering their physique and close combat, which is perfect for a gauntlet user.

Wu Zao had surprisingly decided to join the Golden Array Academy despite being a fan wielder and having never heard of arrays until today, but he was interested in their concept and wanted to see if he could become an Array Master.

Xi Murong, who was an expert with daggers, decided to join the Heavenly Academy with Shi Lang.

Last but not least, Min Li, who also ranked top 10 with everybody else, managed to receive an offer from the Heavenly Academy, which she gladly accepted.

The Demon Sealing Faction and Min Li had managed to occupy 7 of the top 10 spots in the disciple examination. Of course, if Li Jinxi's results were counted, that would make it 8 out of 10 spots, and she would also take rank one without any contenders.

The Seven Spirit Academies were, without doubt, extremely elevated to have so many top-scoring geniuses join their sects at once.

"Thank you, Senior, for allowing me to join the Heavenly Academy! And thank you, Seniors, for offering me a spot in your sects! I am really grateful

to you all!" Min Li bowed to interviewers after joining the Heavenly Academy.

"Our Heavenly Academy is honored to have a genius such as yourself amongst our ranks. Please arrive at the Heavenly Academy within 30 days to start your training. That's all."

"Yes!"

Min Li left the place shortly after and began making her way back to the hotel.

"Now that everyone has finished their examination, let's go meet them at the hotel like we'd planned." Yuan said to the ones with him.

"Okay."

A few hours later, everyone arrived at the hotel.

"Congratulations, everyone, on passing the examination. I had faith that you would all pass." Yuan said.

"Honestly, the examination was much easier than I'd anticipated." Wang Ming said.

"Right? I worried for nothing." Shi Lang laughed.

"By the way, did you hear? Something big happened during the examination. Apparently, someone picked a fight with the Sect Masters of the Seven Spirit Academies. I heard it on the way back here." Wang Bingbing suddenly said.

"Oh! I heard about that too! Which idiot would do such a thing?" Wang Ming said.

"About that..." Yuan chuckled.

"Eh?" Everybody there turned to look at him with raised eyebrows.

"You see..." Yuan proceeded to explain his experience with everyone, leaving them speechless.

"Unbelievable! How dare they try to kill Li Jinxi over something so stupid! Do you think it's too late to leave the sect?!" Wang Ming expressed his anger afterward.

"Why would you do that? Although they may have overreacted, Li Jinxi isn't completely innocent either. Just forget about it and go to the sect. They may not be perfect, but you'll be able to obtain a lot of experience there." Yuan shook his head.

"By the way, as a result of this experience, Li Jinxi will be following me to the next realm."

"Honestly, I'm not surprised. Unlike the rest of us, she has the strength and talent to follow you. Good luck up there, all of you." Shi Lang said.

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Chapter 876 - Because of You

"When are you guys planning on leaving? We have a month before we must report to our new sects." Wang Bingbing asked them.

"We'll most likely leave before then." Yuan said.

After talking for some time, Meixiu and the others logged off Cultivation Online for dinner.

"Yuan, can I borrow you for a bit? It won't be long." Min Li suddenly approached him.

"Sure."

"Follow me."

Min Li then brought Yuan to the balcony.

"What's up?" Yuan decided to start the conversation when Min Li remained silent for many moments.

"I just wanted to thank you before going to the sect. I have decided to leave for the sect tonight." Min Li said with a slight smile on her face.

"Already? You have 30 days, right?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"Yes, but I do not want to continue bothering you." Min Li's smile became bittersweet.

"Because of you, I acquired the courage to deny the Min Family."

"Because of you, I have managed to break free from the Min Family."

"Because of you, I have achieved my lifelong dream of leaving the Lower Heavens."

"Because of you, I can finally walk my cultivation path the way I want."

"I really cannot thank you enough— it's a debt that I will never be able to repay."

Yuan smiled and said, "You don't need to repay me. You're my friend, and it's only natural for friends to help each other out. I know I told you this before, too."

"You're right... Sorry I even brought it up."

Min Li turned to look at the bright moon, and after a moment of silence, she spoke, "Do you think we'll see each other again? I know you'll only continue to ascend the Nine Heavens while I am stuck here."

"We'll see each other again. I will make sure to visit you when I get the chance in the future." Yuan smiled.

However, Min Li shook her head and said, "No, I will be the one to visit you. I will train hard and catch up to you no matter how long it will take me, and I will continue to ascend the Nine Heavens until we meet again."

"If you don't mind, I have two more selfish requests for you. Please wait for me."

"Sure." Yuan nodded without hesitation.

After a moment of silence, Yuan spoke, "You said you have two requests for me, right? That was just one."

Min Li immediately blushed, "A-Actually, forget about my second request... I will tell you about it during our next meeting. Instead, can you close your eyes for a moment?"

Yuan silently nodded and closed his eyes.

The moment Yuan closed his eyes, Min Li tipped her toes and leaned forward, kissing Yuan on his soft lips.

"Please keep them closed for a little longer. I don't want you to see my face right now." Min Li quickly said after removing her lips.

After a moment of awkward silence, Min Li said, "I may not be worthy to be with you now, but I will train hard to become someone worthy. Until next time, Yuan."

Yuan suddenly felt a gentle gust of wind caress his face. He opened his eyes to see that Min Li had disappeared from the balcony.

He turned to look in a certain direction and touched his lips.

'Why do they always ask me to close my eyes?' He wondered inwardly.

Ding!

A distinct noise suddenly snapped Yuan out of his daze.

<'Min Li' has been added to your Bond!>

<Min Li's Bond level has increased to Intimate!>

<Congratulations! Your Bond level with Min Li has reached Intimate!>

<You have gained the following effect from Min Li's Bond level: 'Min Li's Adoration'>

[Min Li's Adoration: Increases your Charm by 40 and Overall Damage by 30%]

Yuan logged off Cultivation Online shortly after and gathered in the dining room to eat dinner with the others.

"You guys can do whatever you want for the next few days. I still have some business to do before we can head to the Stairway to Heaven." Yuan said to Meixiu and the others.

"Okay." *[Updated from Freewebnovel.com]*

The following day.

"Feng Feng, let's return to the House of Riches. They're probably waiting for us." Yuan said to her.

"Oh, I nearly forgot that we'd asked for their help regarding the Pill of Truth. Let's go."

On their way to the House of Riches, Xiao Hua asked, "Why are you looking for the Pill of Truth?"

"It's a long story." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Then shorten it..." Xiao Hua frowned.

Feng Yuxiang chuckled and proceeded to briefly explain the situation to Xiao Hua, "Basically, we need the Pill of Truth to see if the Young Master's memories are real."

"Memories? Is there something wrong with your memories, Brother Yuan?" Xiao Hua turned to look at him with a puzzled face.

"No, it's nothing of that sort. I haven't told you this yet because you were away with Min Li, but I actually have memories of my past life as the Divine Paragon."

"W-What...?" Xiao Hua's eyes immediately widened.

"I know it's hard to believe, but it's the truth. I even recall my birthplace and my family during that life. In fact, I—the Divine Paragon was born in the third heaven—our next destination."

"Reincarnation..." Xiao Hua mumbled in a low voice, her thoughts unknown.

Seeing Xiao Hua in deep thoughts, Yuan stopped talking so that she could think.

Meanwhile, inside the Universal Music Academy, a man dressed in completely black stood before Sun Hao inside his quarters.

"Is this information real?" Sun Hao turned to look at the man with a wide smile on his face.

"Yes, I have confirmed it myself. The Gu Family is currently searching for a young man named 'Yuan'. They seem to have some grievances with him." The man said.

"Hahaha! This is perfect! Let the Gu Family know that I have information on this 'Yuan' and that I want to meet with them! Immediately!"

"Right away!" The man immediately left the room.

"What a coincidence that the Gu Family is looking for that bastard! This must be Heaven's calling! They must want that bastard dead as much as I do! Hahaha!" Sun Hao laughed inwardly.

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Chapter 877 - It Wasn't Robbery

Chapter 877 - It Wasn't Robbery

After arriving at the House of Riches, Yuan and his group walked into the building to find out that there was an ongoing auction.

"Welcome, how may I—" The man at the counter suddenly stopped talking.

"I-It's you! Please wait for a moment, Esteemed Guests! I will immediately notify Senior Gu of your arrival!"

The man immediately rushed upstairs. Ever since his last encounter with Yuan and Feng Yuxiang, the man had engraved their faces into his mind, fearing that he might offend them again.

Gu Xiulan could be seen rushing downstairs a few moments later.

"Welcome back, Esteemed Guests! I have been anticipating your arrival!" She said to them with a bright smile on her face. Clearly, she had some good news.

Once they were inside the VIP room, Feng Yuxiang said, "So? Did you find any information on the Pill of Truth? Judging by your demeanor, you found something, right?"

"Yes. While I have to announce with regret that the Pill of Truth doesn't exist in this world, I have been told by a reliable source that someone in the Third Heaven has one."

And she continued, "His name is Jin Sang, and he's a renowned Tier 5 Alchemy Master at the Spirit Grass Mountain."

"Thank you for the information, but if you want the Spirit Jade, you'll need to give me some concrete proof. I can't just accept your words so quickly.

What if I give you the Spirit Jade and it turns out the information is wrong? That would be foolish of me." Feng Yuxiang said.

"I-I assure you that this information is very trustworthy! Although I cannot give you any information about my sources, I am willing to put the House of Riches' name and reputation on my words!"

Feng Yuxiang silently stared at Gu Xiulan for a moment before turning to look at Yuan, "What do you think, Young Master? Should we trust her information?"

"I don't see why we shouldn't. They're a reputable name, right? And we're the ones who asked them for help. I think it would be rude of us to not trust them after all that."

"If the Young Master trusts them, I will also trust them."

"Here."

Feng Yuxiang took out the Spirit Jade from her spatial ring and tossed it at Gu Xiulan, treating it as though it was only a piece of candy.

Gu Xiulan's heart skipped a beat when she saw this, and she hastily caught the Spirit Jade, sighing in relief afterward.

"Even though you don't really deserve this Spirit Jade because I told you to find the Pill of Truth, and you only found information about it, I am feeling generous today." Feng Yuxiang said.

"T-Thank you, Esteemed Guest!"

Although the House of Riches is incredibly wealthy and 100 million spirit stones isn't much to them, it doesn't mean Gu Xiulan owns its wealth, as she is only a manager of this auction house. However, since this is a private deal between Feng Yuxiang and Gu Xiulan, she would be able to pocket all of the money to herself after paying the people she asked for help.

"Shall we go now, Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang asked him.

"Yes, let's—"

"P-Please wait!" Gu Xiulan suddenly stopped them.

"What do you want?" Feng Yuxiang asked.

"I know I shouldn't stick my nose into your business, and I have no intention to, but I have some additional information for you. Of course, this is on the house and you don't need to pay me for it."

Feng Yuxiang narrowed her eyes and said, "So you withheld information about the Pill of Truth from us?"

"N-No! That's not it! This is a completely different matter!" She immediately refuted such claims.

"In case you don't already know about my background, I am actually from the Seven Legacy Families—the Gu Family. According to what I've been told, the Gu Family from the Lower Heavens had been robbed by someone named 'Yuan'."

"Oh? Is that so?" Yuan remained calm even after hearing such information.

"How did you know I was 'Yuan'? I don't remember giving you my name."

Feng Yuxiang narrowed her eyes at Gu Xiulan, who swallowed nervously.

'If I answer wrongly, I will be killed!' She cried inwardly.

"T-That's because the Gu Family from the Lower Heavens also gave us descriptions of you. I noticed it at first during our first encounter, but I didn't think it was you at that time. After the Flood Dragon's Scale auction, Senior Nie told me your name, and that's when I realized it."

"Senior Nie? Oh, right. He was there as well." Yuan remembered seeing Senior Nie after the auction.

"And you haven't told the Gu Family about us? Why not?" Feng Yuxiang suddenly asked.

"Honestly, I don't want to help those idiots from the Lower Heavens. I don't know why you decided to rob them when you can easily hand out 100 million spirit stones without any hesitation, but that's none of my business. They probably even deserved it."

"I see... And how is their search going?" Feng Yuxiang then asked.

"They're still looking. It's not easy looking for people based on just their names and description, especially if they're not natives of this world, after all. In fact, it would be easier to find a needle in a haystack the size of a mountain."

"Thank you for this information, but I must clear up something. We didn't rob them." Yuan said.

"Huh? You didn't? So they lied?" Gu Xiulan was left speechless by this information.

"It was a donation. They donated their treasures to me after I punished them a little for trying to take my friend by force. That's all there is to it." Yuan said with a smile.

"I-I see... In that case, they definitely deserved it. I apologize for sticking my nose into your business. Once again, thank you for the Spirit Jade and trusting me. I hope to do business again with you in the future." Gu Xiulan bowed to them.

Yuan and Feng Yuxiang left the House of Riches shortly after, returning to the hotel.

Chapter 878 - Hidden Formation

"What should we do about the Gu Family, Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang asked him after they left the House of Riches.

"It's simple. We will do nothing." Yuan said.

"First of all, they don't even know about our location or our identity. We're also leaving this world soon, so unless they somehow manage to find us before then, there's no point to even think about it."

"If they somehow manage to find us... We'll deal with it then."

"I understand." Feng Yuxiang nodded and said nothing else.

After returning to the hotel, Yuan logged off.

"I'll see you guys later. I have some business that I need to take care of, so I won't appear for a while. Don't worry, it won't be longer than a few days." Yuan said to Xiao Hua and the others before logging off.

Once he returned to his world, Yuan picked up his phone and dialed a certain number.

"Hello? Manager? This is Yuan. I'd like to speak with the Lord. Please schedule an appointment for me." Yuan said.

"No. The Lord doesn't do appointments. He will call you when he needs you." The Manager coldly refused.

"Don't be so cold. This is about the demons in the mountain. Of course, if you want somebody else to deal with them, I will stop bothering you."

"..."

The Manager was dead silent for a good moment before she spoke, "I will speak with the Lord."

Di.

She immediately hung up afterward.

'She really hates me, huh?' Yuan chuckled inwardly.

'What should I do now while I wait for a response?'

However, before he could even think of anything, his phone began ringing again.

"Hello?"

"Get ready. I am coming to pick you up now." The Manager said.

"You already spoke to the Lord? It hasn't even been a minute since our last conversation—"

Di.

The Manager closed the connection before he could even finish his sentence.

Yuan quickly got dressed and went outside to wait for the Manager after leaving behind a note for Chu Liuxiang, who was diligently cultivating in the balcony.

About ten minutes after their phone call, the Manager showed up in front of Yuan's living quarters.

"Let's go." She said.

"You know, you don't have to pick me up everytime. I know the way by now." Yuan suddenly said to her.

The Manager stopped walking and turned to look at him with a serious face.

"Do you really know the way?"

"Of course." He nodded.

"Then you can take the lead," she said, even gesturing for him to walk ahead of her.

Yuan merely smiled and began walking in front of her.

About half an hour later, Yuan stopped walking, and he looked at the road in front of him with a pondering face.

"What's the matter? Why did you stop?" The Manager asked him.

"We should've arrived at the peak of the mountain by now, but I cannot see the peak nearby even with my divine sense."

"Ridiculous." The Manager scoffed.

"Wait." Yuan suddenly said.

After a moment of silence, he smiled, "I see... No wonder why you told me to lead you. There's a powerful formation that keeps others from ever reaching the peak, am I right?"

The Manager narrowed her eyes slightly.

"Not bad. Now you know why I have to take you there. Besides the Lord and myself, the formation will keep all existence away from the peak."

"I understand now, but I still want to try to reach the peak." Yuan said, dumbfounding the Manager.

"Did you not hear what I just said?" She frowned afterward.

"I heard you loud and clear. Now that I understand it, I can deal with it. As long as I can figure out the trick to this formation, I should be able to reach

the peak without your help."

"I would love to see you try, but we don't have the time for that. The Lord is waiting for you. If you make him wait too long..."

"Don't worry, this won't take too long." Yuan said as he took a seat on the street.

"..."

Even though the Manager was confident that Yuan would not be able to bypass the formation, she couldn't help but stare at him with interest.

Meanwhile, Yuan studied the formation with his divine sense.

'This formation is well hidden. It's no wonder why I didn't see it at first. Unless you're actively looking for it, you will most likely miss it— No, it actively tries to disguise itself, so you won't find it even if you know about its existence.'

'Formations... Although they are not considered arrays due to their size and complexity, they function about the same.'

Five minutes later, Yuan stood up and turned to look at the Manager with a smile on his face.

'N-No way... Did he really manage to crack the formation? And in such a short time?' She wondered inwardly, even feeling a little excited.

However, what came out of Yuan's mouth a second later made her fume in anger.

"You were right, I couldn't crack it. Sorry." Yuan said with a playful smile on his face.

"Y-You little bastard..." The Manager's eyebrows twitched aggressively, and her face twisted in anger.

"How dare you mess with me! If the Lord wasn't waiting for you, I wouldn't hesitate to beat you up right now! Hmph!" The Manager snorted before stomping ahead of him.

Yuan shrugged and said, "I'm not trying to make any excuses for myself by saying this, but the reason I couldn't crack the formation is because I don't recognize half of the array symbols that make up the formation. If I understood the symbols, I would've been able to crack it."

"Judging by the complexity of these symbols, they're probably level 4 or 5 array symbols. I only know up to level 3 and a little of level 4 array symbols. Once I learn level 4 and level 5 array symbols, I will try again."

"Whatever." The Manager said.

Even though Yuan wasn't able to crack the formation on his first attempt, the Manager was still impressed that he'd even managed to see the formation in the first place. Of course, she would never admit that she was impressed by him, even if she was threatened with death.

Chapter 879 - How Confident Are You?

Five minutes after the Manager took back the lead, they arrived at the peak of the Dragon Spiral Mountain.

Yuan immediately walked to the cave and stood in front of it.

"Did something happen on your way here? You're late." The Lord's voice resounded from deep within the cave a moment later.

"Not really. I wanted to try cracking the formation that is protecting this place." Yuan said with a calm smile.

The Lord was surprised by his words and couldn't find any words for a good moment.

"Hahaha!" He suddenly started laughing.

"So you found the formation, huh? Not bad! Not bad at all!"

After getting a good laugh, the Lord continued, "So, what business do you have with me— with the demons?"

"It's nothing that important, but it's about time I deal with those pests. It doesn't feel good knowing that you're living so close to demons, you know? It's like living in a house with the knowledge that there are insects dwelling in your basement. It makes my skin crawl just thinking about it." Yuan said.

"..."

The Lord didn't immediately respond, but he could tell that something had changed about Yuan, who appeared to be a totally different person right now.

"You say you want to deal with them, but how are you going to achieve that?" The Lord asked a moment later.

"It's simple. I will drag them out of the mountain and deal with them one by one. After all, there's no reason why we should wait for them to break out of their seal. The best time to strike is when they're sealed and unable to defend themselves."

"That is an interesting but reckless plan. How confident are you? Can you say with certainty that you can defeat the demons at your current state without any troubles?"

"Yes, I can, and I won't be fighting them myself. The Demon Sealing Faction will also be there."

"How daring... and risky." The Lord said in a pondering voice.

"They will eventually break out of their seals, and that day is not far in the future. We can train until we collapse everyday until they break out of their seal, but I doubt it would make that much of a difference."

"While there is truth in your words, I don't know if I can completely trust you. What if you fail to kill the demons and they destroy my precious mountain?"

"If you don't trust my abilities, then why did you even ask me to deal with your demon problem?" Yuan said as he calmly stared into the pitch-black cave.

"This and that are two different matters. You're being impatient right now, and you're acting differently than usual. I don't know if I can trust you in your current state." The Lord said.

Yuan sighed after hearing the Lord's words.

"Fine. Then you can find someone else to deal with the demons. The Demon Sealing Faction will move out of the Dragon Spiral Mountain as soon as possible since I won't be able to fulfill your request."

And without waiting for the Lord's response, Yuan turned around and began walking away.

"You insolent brat!" The Manager shouted at him.

However, Yuan ignored her and continued walking.

"Where do you think you're going?"

An immense pressure suddenly appeared from the Lord's cave, halting Yuan's movements.

"Did you already forget about the formation? It works both ways, so you won't be able to leave here by yourself." The Lord said in a cold voice.

Yuan turned to look at the cave in a stiff manner with the pressure making it hard for him to move.

"Judging by your aura, you're probably a Spirit Emperor... Perhaps even a Spirit Sovereign. However, that should be impossible with the quality of spiritual energy in this world even if you cultivated for millions of years—that is if you cultivated in this world."

"You... You're not from this world, are you? Let me guess... You're from Cultivation Online— or should I call it the Nine Heavens?"

The Lord's pressure suddenly disappeared, and the place became dead silent.

The Manager was also staring at Yuan with a profound frown on her face, seemingly trying to come to a conclusion.

Yuan turned to look at the Manager after sensing killing intent from her.

"I know you hate me, but I didn't think you hate me enough to want to kill me. However, are you sure you really want to do that?"

"I am no match for a Spirit Emperor with my current strength, much less a Spirit Sovereign, so I am currently at your mercy. However, if you kill me, you can kiss the Dragon Spiral Mountain goodbye when the demons come out of their seals."

Yuan suddenly laid on the ground and spread his limbs out like he was stretching.

"Go ahead. Kill me. I won't defend myself."

"Stand down, Liya." The Lord's voice resounded, breaking the awkward silence.

And he continued, "You... Who are you? You're not the Yuan I know."

Yuan smiled and said, "It's rude to ask for one's identity while being in a place where they cannot even see you, much less identify you."

"I have my circumstances." The Lord said.

"What a coincidence. I also have my circumstances. However, I can tell you that I am indeed Yuan. Whether you believe me or not... I don't care."

After another long moment of silence, the Lord spoke, "I will ask you again. How confident are you? Can you promise me that you won't mess this up? The Dragon Spiral Mountain is much more important than you can ever imagine. If the demons destroy it, it will be the end of this world."

Yuan raised his eyebrows after hearing the Lord's seemingly outrageous claims.

"I won't make any promises, but I can say with confidence that I have never lost to a demon before." Yuan said, not counting his defeat in the Demon Sealing Pagoda.

A defeated sigh echoed from the cave a moment later.

"Very well. Do as you please. However, if you screw up, I will personally kill you even if it's the last thing I do." The Lord said.

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Chapter 880 - 26 Days

"Good. Now that it's been decided, I want to see the demons right now." Yuan said.

"Bring him to the demons. And don't do anything funny, Liya." The Lord said to the Manager.

"I won't." She said in a nonchalant voice.

"Follow me."

Yuan nodded and silently followed the Manager to the area with the 11 demons.

Once they arrived, Yuan began analyzing the demons one by one by putting his hand onto it and checking their prowess.

Some minutes later, Yuan pointed at a specific demon and said to the Manager, "I want this demon. Can you deliver it to the back of my house by this afternoon?"

The Manager frowned and said, "Are you insane? What do you think this place is? A convenience store where you can buy demons and have them delivered?"

"Well... I don't mind taking care of the demons here, but are you sure you want that? It's going to get messy, and we could accidentally break the other demons out of their seal in the process."

"Although I don't care if the Dragon Spiral Mountain is destroyed or not, I don't think the Lord will like that very much."

"Che." The Manager coldly snorted.

"Fine, we will deliver it to you by this afternoon. What else do you want?"

Yuan suddenly summoned the Empyrean Overlord and began writing on the ground in front of the sealed demons, numbering them from one to eleven in addition to dates.

"The numbers dictate the order these demons will break out of their seal, and the date is the exact day they will break out of their seal. I want you to deliver the demons three days prior to their dates. Simple, right?"

The Manager didn't say anything at first and walked around to look at the dates.

"The first demon to break out of their seal is in 5 days, and the last demon will break out of their seal in 26 days... We have less than a month to deal with all 11 demons?" The Manager mumbled, sounding slightly worried.

She turned to look at Yuan and asked, "How accurate are your accessements?"

"Although I can't tell the exact second the demons will break out of their seal until the very last few hours, I am confident that they will break out on those days. However, just in case, I want you to bring them to me three days prior to their dates." Yuan said.

"And what are you going to do once I deliver these demons to you?" The Manager continued to ask.

Yuan smiled and said, "You're free to stay behind and experience it with your very own eyes."

"I will be doing that even without needing you to tell me."

"Great. Then I will see you in a few hours." Yuan said as he walked towards the exit.

Once they returned to the Lord, Yuan said, "I am going to return home for now to prepare."

"You can ask for the details from her." He pointed at the Manager.

"Liya, show him the exit." The Lord said.

The Manager then led Yuan until they left the formation.

"See you later, Liya." Yuan chuckled.

"I don't recall giving you the permission to use my name." The Manager frowned.

"What's the harm? I have a feeling that we'll become friends in the near future, so we might as well start now."

"In your dreams." The Manager sneered before leaving him to return to the peak of the mountain.

Once she returned to the Lord's side, she explained the situation to him.

"I see... So we have 26 days to deal with the demons..."

The Manager then asked in a concerned voice, "Can we really trust him?"

After a moment of silence, the Lord spoke, "Although I don't know what had happened to him to cause such a drastic change in personality, he's definitely more formidable than before. And we're in no position to be picky. We have no choice but to trust him for now."

The Manager then said in a low voice, "When he was with the demons earlier, I could smell anger and hatred in his scent. I don't want to trust him, but I believe that he truly despises demons for some reason."

"That's good enough for me." The Lord said.

Meanwhile, after returning to his home, Yuan called for everyone in the Demon Sealing Faction.

Once everyone was gathered, Yuan said to them, "This is a little sudden, but I need you all to prepare yourselves."

"What happened?" Wu Zao asked.

"We're going to be fighting a demon soon," he replied in a calm voice.

"What?! A demon?!" They all exclaimed.

"This is certainly very sudden! Where are we going to fight the demon?" Wang Ming asked.

"Here. In our backyard."

"What...?"

Their eyes widened with shock after hearing such words.

"The Manager will be delivering a demon to our backyard later this afternoon, and I am going to let you all fight it." Yuan revealed another piece of shocking information.

"W-Wait. You're going to make us fight the demon?" Shi Lang swallowed nervously.

"Yes. You can't expect me to fight all of the demons by myself, right? Although I can certainly kill all of the demons by myself, that would make your efforts pointless."

"You all learned demon sealing techniques for a reason, or am I wrong?"

"No, you're right." Wang Bingbing said with a resolute expression on her face.

"Don't worry, I won't force you to fight if you don't want to."

"I will fight!" Wang Ming immediately said.

"Me too." Xi Murong raised his hand.

Once everyone there agreed to fight, Yuan nodded and said, "Good, then meet me in the backyard this afternoon."

The others immediately stormed off to prepare for the fight.

"Are you two okay?" Yuan asked Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang afterward.

"I would be lying if I said that I'm perfectly fine, but I am not afraid. After all, you're going to be there, right?" Chu Liuxiang said.

"Of course." Yuan nodded.

"Then there's nothing for me to be worried about! I am going to prepare!" Chu Liuxiang said before she left to prepare.

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Chapter 881 - Tian Chenyu

Chapter 881: Tian Chenyu

"What about you? Are you feeling okay?" Yuan asked Meixiu, who was the only one left there.

"Just a little nervous," she said.

"Don't worry, you'll be fine. You might be startled by the demon's appearance and aura at first, but remember, you have trained under my killing intent." Yuan smiled.

"Un." She nodded.

Once Meixiu also left to prepare, Yuan returned to his room and sat on the balcony with a zither in his lap, and for the next few hours, until it was time to gather at the backyard, he would play with the zither that once belonged to Azure.

'Two... I have already lost two people that were precious to me to demons. There will not be another... I will do everything in my power to kill all demons.' Yuan sighed inwardly as he recalled his memories as Tian Chenyu.

Sitting atop a small green hill were two figures, a young man and a young lady, both seemingly around 16 years old.

The young man had a scroll in his grasp and appeared to be studying its contents with great focus. Meanwhile, sitting right beside him, the young lady appeared to be fiddling with flowers.

"Chenyu! Look!" A sweet but clear voice resounded.

"What is it?" Tian Chenyu responded without looking away from the scroll.

"I said look, not listen! Come on! You won't die if you stop studying for a day!"

Tian Chenyu sighed and placed his scroll down before turning to look at the beautiful young lady sitting beside him.

"You know the scholar examination is next week. You even promised that you wouldn't bother me if I came out here with you. If I fail this examination, I will have to wait another four years before I can retake it."

"Don't be so stingy. Do you know how many people would die to spend time with me? You should consider yourself lucky that I chose you. And with your intelligence, I'm sure you can pass the examination even without studying."

"You chose me? Or do you mean our families chose each other?" Tian Chenyu shook his head.

Indeed, he was engaged to this young lady, but that was a decision made by their families.

"While that is true, I still have control over my own feelings, and I personally want to be with you," she said with a slightly rosy face.

"..." Tian Chenyu also began blushing, and the two of them would silently and awkwardly stare at each other for the next few seconds.

"A-Anyways! Look at this wreath I just finished! I made it using the flowers in this area. Isn't it beautiful?"

Tian Chenyu looked at the headdress made of white flowers in her hands and shrugged.

"Here, let me help you put it on."

"Who said I want to wear..."

Before Tian Chenyu could even finish his sentence, the young lady placed the wreath on his head.

"Hehe... You look even weaker than usual now..." She chuckled.

"So annoying..." Tian Chenyu mumbled to himself. However, despite his annoyance with her, he didn't remove the crown of flowers on his head.

Instead, he picked up his scroll and went right back to reading it.

The young lady smiled at his reaction, and then she positioned her body before laying her head on Tian Chenyu's legs.

Tian Chenyu acted as though he didn't even notice it and continued reading his scroll.

The two of them remained in that position for the next few hours until the sun was beginning to set.

"It's about time I go home. I won't be able to see you for another month because of my cultivation lessons, but I will come see you as soon as that is over."

"So I will have a month of peace, huh? It's been a while." Tian Chenyu said as he packed his scrolls and stood up.

"How horrible. Do you really hate being around me that much?" The young lady said with a puffed face as she tried to act angry.

"What do you think?" Tian Chenyu said.

She pondered for a moment before responding with a cheeky smile, "I think you love me but you're just too shy to admit it."

"Whatever." Tian Chenyu nonchalantly said, and he began walking down the hill.

"Wait for me!" The young lady quickly grabbed her stuff before chasing after him.

After walking for about 20 minutes, the two of them returned to the city.

"Chenyu, I know it'll only be a month, but promise me that you won't forget about me." The young lady suddenly said.

"Really?" Tian Chenyu looked at her with a weird face.

The young lady didn't respond and merely stared at him intently.

Tian Chenyu sighed and said, "I promise I won't forget you."

The young lady immediately smiled, "Then I will see you next month, darling!"

Tian Chenyu's entire body trembled when the young lady called him 'darling', but before he could even say anything, the young lady turned around and ran away with a flushed face.

After returning home, Tian Chenyu's father approached him and asked, "How was your day with Lady Ai Rong?"

"It was horrible, and I couldn't get any studying done. Why did you even agree to let me go out with her when you know my examination is next week?"

"How could I refuse such a beautiful young lady asking to spend time with my own son? I would lose my qualifications as a father if I refused."

"Whatever. I'm going back to my room to study. You don't have to cook my share for dinner tonight." Tian Chenyu said before disappearing into the house.

"He's still having difficulties expressing his emotions, huh?" A beautiful woman suddenly appeared and sighed.

"He's already finished his studies two months ago, yet he still pretends to be studying. Why can't he just be honest and accept his feelings for Lady Ai Rong?" Tian Chenyu's father sighed.

"Lady Ai Rong, on the other hand, is very expressive and honest about her feelings for him. It feels like their role as a man and woman are flipped.

What a troubled young man my son is..." The woman sighed as well.

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Chapter 882 - Fascinated

Chapter 882: Fascinated

After returning to his room, Tian Chenyu dropped the scrolls on the floor and went straight to his bed.

He laid down and proceeded to stare at the ceiling with a blank look on his face.

'Why can't I be honest whenever I am with her? What's wrong with me?' He sighed inwardly as Ai Rong's face appeared inside his head.

He eventually fell asleep on his bed thinking about his day with Ai Rong, and while he slept, he would continue to dream of their time together.

A week later, Tian Chenyu left his house early to take the scholar examination.

While Ai Rong wanted to become a cultivator, Tian Chenyu wanted to follow his father's path as a scholar.

Of course, Ai Rong has tried to convince Tian Chenyu to become a cultivator with her, but he did not like violence, and with cultivators being symbolic of violence in his era, it was near impossible to convince him to become a cultivator.

Once he arrived at the site of the examination, Tian Chenyu went inside and immediately began his examination.

The examination consisted of many complicated and philosophical questions that could take six hours to complete even for talented individuals.

However, when Tian Chenyu took the examination, it took him less than an hour to finish, shocking everyone there.

"That was Tian Aowei's son, Tian Chenyu, right? I have heard about his talents, but I didn't think he would be this crazy..."

"Looks like his father will finally have a rival."

Tian Chenyu immediately returned home after finishing his examinations.

"You're back already?" Tian Aowei, his father, was surprised to see him back so soon.

"Yes, the examination was much easier than anticipated."

"Now that you're done with the examination, you'll have plenty of time to spend with Lady Ai Rong." His mother began to tease him.

"I-I don't even like—"

"Who do you think you're trying to fool? My 16 years of experience as your mother isn't for naught, Chenyu."

"Anyway, Lady Ai Rong is currently busy with her cultivation, but when she is finished, I want you to go see her. It's always Lady Ai Rong who visits you, so you're going to be the one to visit her this time, and I won't take no for an answer."

"Do you understand what I just said?"

"I understand..." Tian Chenyu nodded while sighing inwardly.

"Good."

Tian Chenyu returned to his room shortly after, but he quickly became bored.

'Although it can get quite annoying with her around, it's also incredibly boring without her...' He sighed.

'What am I going to do for the next three weeks? The examinations are over, and I don't feel like studying anymore.'

He suddenly turned to look at a certain object hanging behind his door.

That object was a sword. It was given to him by his parents just in case he needed to protect himself, but he has never used it before.

'Why would she want to become a cultivator? Cultivators are violent in nature, and they are at higher risk of being targeted by demons because their bodies absorb spiritual energy, so they are tastier than mortals who are without any spiritual energy to demons. I really don't understand her...'

'Fortunately for us, demons rarely come to this area, and when they do, they will eat a few dozen people before leaving us alone.'

Sometime later, Tian Chenyu sat before his study table and began flipping through pages of a book.

However, this book doesn't contain information that he would normally study.

'So this is what a demon looks like... I have never seen one before...' Tian Chenyu mumbled to himself as he read about demons.

'They are immortal beings that cannot be killed even if their heads and brains are crushed. You can cut their bodies in half and tear off all their limbs, but they will regenerate everything like nothing had even happened... Heavens... How do you even fight these monsters if they're so powerful?'

The more Tian Chengyu studied about demons the more intrigued and fascinated he became about their species, and it would quickly become his hobby to study about demons.

For the next three weeks, Tian Chenyu would study nonstop about demons until he read every book and scroll that existed within the city, and when he

had nothing new to read, he would read through everything for a second and even third time.

After studying so much about demons, Tian Chenyu felt like he knew everything about demons. However, no matter how much he read about them, there was one thing that he could not understand.

'What is it like to encounter a demon?' He wondered.

Regardless how knowledgeable he was on demons, he could not understand what it would feel like to encounter a real demon.

Knock *Knock*

"Chenyu, are you awake?" His mother suddenly knocked on the door.

"Yes, I am."

"I just received news from the Ai Family that Lady Ai Rong will finish her cultivation lessons today. Do you remember what I told you three weeks ago?"

"Yes, I remember..." Tian Chenyu responded with a bittersweet smile on his face.

"Good, then go and fulfill your duties as her fiancée and as a man."

"I will."

Tian Chenyu said, and he left his room after cleaning his desk.

Right as he reached the doors, his mother showed up again and handed him a wooden basket, "Enjoy this food with the Ai Family."

"Okay."

"One more thing. Rumor has it that someone had spotted a demon near our city three days ago, so don't stay out too late. After all, if you encounter a demon, you are almost guaranteed to die."

"I know." Tian Chenyu accepted the basket and began making his way towards the Ai Family that was about an hour walk from his house.

About half way there, Tian Chenyu stopped walking when he heard someone shouting in a hysterical voice, "R-Run! A demon has appeared on the east side of the city, and it is going through houses, eating the families inside!"

'The east side...? That's where the Ai Family is located! Ai Rong!'

Upon realizing this fact, Tian Chenyu dropped the basket in his grasp and began running, but he was not going back home. Instead, he continued to make his way towards the Ai Family.

'Please be safe, Ai Rong!' He constantly prayed in his heart as he ran, tumbling to the ground multiple times on his way there.

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Chapter 883 - Ai Rong

Chapter 883: Ai Rong

'Please be safe, Ai Rong! Please be safe! I promise that I will start being honest to you with my feelings!' Tian Chenyu continued to run towards the east side of the city even though he was already out of breath.

"Hide! A demon has appeared on the east side of the city!" The pedestrians shouted as they ran.

"Young man, where are you going?! That's the direction of the demon!"

Some of the pedestrians tried to stop Tian Chenyu, but he ignored all of their warnings and continued running.

A few minutes later, which felt like an eternity for Tian Chenyu, he finally arrived in the area where the Ai Family was located.

However, the place was awfully quiet, a stark contrast to the atmosphere on the other side of the city.

Tian Chenyu eventually arrived at the Ai Family's household, and he could even see their entrance.

However, he couldn't approach the household for some reason and could only stand a couple of houses away.

He eventually snapped out of his daze and proceeded walking towards the Ai Family's household.

But then he came to another halt when he noticed a figure appearing from within the household, and this person appeared to be running away from something.

When Tian Chenyu saw the pretty face of this person, a smile immediately appeared on his face.

'Ai Rong!'

Indeed, it was Ai Rong, his love since childhood and fiancée.

Tian Chenyu felt all of the weight on his shoulders disappear the moment he saw that Ai Rong was still alive. Even though she looked terrified and completely hysterical at this moment, that didn't matter to him.

However, before he could even sigh a breath of relief, and before the smile on his face could fully be formed, something red and long appeared behind Ai Rong, and it was flying towards her direction like a spear.

Before Tian Chenyu could even fully comprehend what he was seeing, the red spear reached Ai Rong and pierced her body from the back.

Ai Rong fell to the ground the very next moment and laid there, but she was still alive.

Seeing this, Tian Chenyu immediately began running towards her.

However, before he could even take two steps, he noticed a red figure appearing behind Ai Rong.

This figure had dark red skin, and it had the frame of a tall human adult. There was also a very distinct-looking horn poking from the right side of its head.

The moment Tian Chenyu saw this demon, his body froze, almost as though he'd turned into a stone statue.

'What are you doing, Tian Chenyu?! Move! Move, damn it!' He roared inwardly.

But no matter how much he tried to command his body to move, it simply refused to listen to him, so he could only stand there and watch as the

demon slowly approached Ai Rong, who was squirming on the ground in a puddle of her own blood.

'No... Don't... Stop it... STOP IT!'

Tian Chenyu wanted to shout at the demon to stop, but no voices came out of his mouth.

Tears flowed from Tian Chenyu's eyes as he watched the demon open its grotesque mouth and clamp down on Ai Rong's legs before tearing it right off her body.

Ai Rong immediately screamed in pain, and her sharp and painful voice felt like daggers piercing his heart when it reached Tian Chenyu.

Meanwhile, the demon chewed on her leg and swallowed it within seconds.

"DELICIOUS!" The demon began laughing afterward, and it immediately went for another bite, taking another chunk of Ai Rong's flesh from her body.

However, Tian Chenyu could do nothing but watch in horror and fear.

Eventually, Ai Rong could no longer scream, so she just laid there as the demon continued to eat her body.

Once half of Ai Rong's body was consumed, Tian Chenyu noticed that Ai Rong was looking in his direction, and her lips appeared to be moving.

Tian Chenyu subconsciously read her lips, which said, "Chen...yu... R... u...n..."

After reading her lips, Tian Chenyu regained enough strength to move his arms, and he lifted his arms towards Ai Rong's direction, seemingly trying to reach for her.

Seeing Tian Chenyu's motion, a slight smile appeared on Ai Rong's face, and her lips continued to move, "I... love... you..."

"Goodbye..."

After saying her last words, the light in Ai Rong's eyes faded, and at the same moment, her life ended.

However, that didn't stop the demon from consuming the rest of her body. In the end, the demon consumed even the last drop of her blood from the ground.

After the demon finished eating Ai Rong, it turned around and went back inside the household.

Once the demon was no longer in his view, Tian Chenyu fell to his knees, and he would spend many minutes staring at the stained ground in front of the Ai Family's household.

The demon would end up eating everybody in the Ai Family and many other families before leaving the city unharmed.

Tian Chenyu wouldn't return home until it was past midnight, and when he did, his worried parents were there to greet him.

"Chenyu! Where have you been?! A demon had appeared in the city! We've been worried to death about you!" His mother immediately went to embrace him.

However, she stopped when there was no reaction from Tian Chenyu.

"C-Chenyu? What happened to you, dear?" She gasped in shock when she saw the blank look on Tian Chenyu's face.

Even though he was clearly alive, he also appeared to be dead at the same time, almost like a soulless vessel.

Tian Aowei then spoke in a low voice, "I had a bad feeling when I heard that the demon had appeared in the east side of the city..."

"Don't tell me... The Ai Family?!"

Realizing the truth, Tian Chenyu's mother embraced him even harder while crying at the same time.

"I'm sorry, Chenyu... I'm really sorry..."

Tian Chenyu eventually fell unconscious in his mother's embrace. When that happened, his family carried him to his bed so that he could rest, and they would call a doctor for him the following morning.

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Chapter 884 - Tian Chenyu's Awakening

Chapter 884: Tian Chenyu's Awakening

"How is my son, doctor?" Tian Aowei asked after the doctor they hired to check on Tian Chenyu.

"Although there is nothing wrong with him physically, I am afraid that his mind is... lost..."

"W-What is that supposed to mean?! What will happen to my son?!" His mother immediately began crying again.

"He must have experienced something extremely traumatic very recently. That event has stressed his mind to its limits, putting him into a coma. I don't know when he'll wake up... if he'll even wake up... We can only hope for a miracle from the heavens at this moment." The doctor sighed.

"How can that be?!" His mother began crying even harder.

Even though Tian Chenyu was in a coma, his mind was actually conscious, so he was able to hear the doctor's words and his mother crying.

'What's the point of waking up if Ai Rong won't be there when I wake up...'
Tian Chenyu sighed inwardly as he fell deeper into his consciousness.

Days turned into weeks, and weeks turned into months, but there were still no signs of Tian Chenyu waking up from his coma.

Eventually, a whole year would pass without Tian Chenyu waking up even once. However, despite that, his family never gave up on him and took care of him daily.

One year turned into two years, and within the blink of an eye, three years have passed since Ai Rong's death.

"How long do you plan on sleeping?"

One day, an unfamiliar voice resounded inside Tian Chenyu's head, waking his consciousness a little.

'Who's there?'

"My identity isn't important. What's truly important here is you... Your future. Do you really plan on rotting away in your room as a nobody?" The voice returned.

"So what if I rot away? It's not like I have anything to live for anymore." Tian Chenyu sighed.

"How pathetic. You lose a woman and you give up life?"

"Shut up! Ai Rong wasn't just any woman! She was my woman! My childhood friend! My fiancée! My love!"

"Is that why you merely stood there when your love was slowly being consumed by that demon?"

"Is that really why you couldn't even utter a single word?"

"Is that why you didn't even try to help her?"

"There was nothing I could've done in that situation! I am a mortal! I am powerless! If I had the power..."

"So you're telling me that if you had the power that you would have saved her? I don't believe it. You may have been powerless, but you didn't even attempt to help her. You weren't just powerless. You were also spineless— a coward— and utterly useless."

Tian Chenyu couldn't refute the voice's ridicule and could only silently accept the mockery.

The voice would continue to mock Tian Chenyu for the next few minutes before disappearing.

However, the voice would return shortly after.

"I will ask you again. If you truly had the power to defeat demons... What would you do then?"

"If I had the power to defeat demons...?" Tian Chenyu repeated.

After a moment of silence, he would respond in a furious voice, "If I had the power, I would erase all demons from existence! I would become their worst nightmare! I would make them regret ever being born!"

"Is that so? I still don't believe you, but I will give you a chance to prove it."

"Wake up, Tian Chenyu!"

The voice disappeared after saying such words, and Tian Chenyu could suddenly feel a warm sensation coming from somewhere deep within his body, quickly enveloping his entire entity.

And before he was aware, his eyes that had been closed shut for over three years would suddenly open, revealing the world to him once again.

Tian Chenyu sat up on his bed and turned to look at the sword that was still hanging on his door.

He then got off the bed and walked to the sword, picking it up.

Despite having not moved his body for over three years, Tian Chenyu did not feel any fatigue in his body at all. In fact, he's never felt any better, even stronger than ever.

After staring at the sword for a moment, he walked to the center of the room and started swinging it around.

At first, his movements were completely amateurish, and his swings had no experience behind them. However, he would quickly improve.

His family eventually realized that their son had woken up from his coma when the servants passing through his room would hear noises coming from

within.

"Chenyu! I have been so worried! Thank the heavens that you finally woke up! You have been in a coma for three years!" His mother was the first to barge into his room, and she cried for many minutes while hugging him.

"Anyways, why are you swinging that sword around when you just woke up? You should rest some more... I will immediately call for a doctor."

"Rest? I have rested enough." Tian Chenyu said in a nonchalant voice.

"Please leave me alone."

He then forced everyone out of his room before continuing to swing his sword.

"Chenyu?! What's the matter?!"

"Give him some time. He may have woken, but his heart and mind is still..." Tian Aowei sighed.

"Alright..."

However, neither Tian Chenyu's father or mother could have anticipated that 'some time' would actually last much longer than his coma.

Days turned into months, and months turned into years.

Within the blink of an eye, 20 years have passed since Tian Chenyu's awakening.

During this time, Tian Chenyu would remain inside his room doing heaven-knows-what for the majority of the time, and the only times he could be seen outside his room are during times when he needed to clean his body because the stench from his body became too unbearable.

As for his parents, they would continue to support him however they could even when they barely saw or spoke to each other. When Tian Chenyu

began requesting for information on demons, they went out of their way to collect books and scrolls about demons from other cities.

They would gather so many books and scrolls that they had to build multiple storage units around their house just to keep the books from cluttering the house.

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Chapter 885 - I Am Tian Chenyu!

"How long do we have to continue this lifestyle? It's been twenty years since that incident, and I have barely seen my son since then. Although I am happy that he's no longer in a coma, this isn't that much different. I can even count the amount of times we've talked to each other during the past 20 years..." Tian Chenyu's mother sighed out loud, complaining to her husband, Tian Aowei.

"It can take years if not decades for a broken heart to heal. We must be patient," he said.

"What if he never recovers? We're not cultivators. We don't have hundreds of years to spend with each other."

"Then what do you suggest? We cannot force his heart to heal. Or what, do you want another son? Although you're past that age, it's not impossible."

"What? No! I don't want another son! How can you even suggest that? If you're suggesting that we replace Chenyu with another son, how is that any different than abandoning Chenyu?!"

"Calm down, I was just being sarcastic. But there is truly nothing we can do now but be patient."

"It might seem like he's not recovering, but that is not true. Things are much better now than 20 years ago. Nowadays, he leaves his room once a week, but back then, it would be a miracle to see him outside his room even once a month."

"At this rate, I will be an old lady before we can become a real family again."

"Better late than never, right?"

"I guess so..."

"By the way, it's almost that time of the year again. Do you think he'll visit their graves this year?" Tian Aowei suddenly asked.

"Unlikely." She sighed.

"Do you think he'll ever fall in love again? That's another problem we must worry about— our grandchildren..."

"Who knows..." Tian Aowei shook his head.

"Anyways, it's getting late. Goodnight, dear."

"Goodnight."

A week later, right as the Tian Family prepared to visit the Ai Family's gravesites, they received dreadful news that changed their plans.

"What? Demons have entered the city? When did this happen? How many?" Tian Aowei asked the servant who told him the news.

"A-About an hour ago! And there are three demons! They are rampaging the city even as we speak!"

"Shit! Why did they have to show up today on all days?!" Tian Aowei cursed out loud.

And he continued, "Let everyone in the household know about the situation! We will hide underground for the next three days!"

"Yes!"

While the servants in the household began scrambling towards the underground area beneath the Tian Family's household that was created to hide from demons, Tian Aowei and his wife went to warn Tian Chenyu of the situation.

"Chenyu! Hurry up and open the door! Demons have invaded our city, and there are three of them! We must hurry and hide underground until they leave!" His mother banged on his door that was locked shut.

However, there was no response from Tian Chenyu, almost as though he wasn't inside his room.

"Chenyu! Are you asleep?! Wake up!" His mother continued banging on his door.

"Where's Chenyu?!" Tian Aowei showed up shortly after and asked her.

"I don't know! He should be in his room, but he's not responding! What if something had happened to him?!"

"Shit! We don't have much time left! Move! I am going to break down his door!" Tian Aowei said as he approached Tian Chenyu's room.

However, right as he stood in front of the door, the ground suddenly shook, and a loud noise resounded behind them simultaneously.

Tian Aowei and his wife slowly turned around to see a tall shadow standing in a cloud of dust about 20 meters from them.

Once the dust cloud disappeared, the figure within became visible.

'A-A demon?! We're dead!' Tian Aowei cried inwardly as his body trembled in fear from the demon's aura that radiated with killing intent.

"N-No... Not like this..."

His wife directly fell to her knees and began crying the moment she saw the demon.

Once the demon noticed their presence, it began walking towards their direction.

"Mortals, huh? I would've preferred cultivators, but I guess you'll do just fine as an appetizer before my main meal."

The demon licked its lips as it closed their distance within seconds.

Tian Aowei and his wife remained frozen as the demon stood right before them, as they were too terrified to even run away.

"I love you, darling..." Tian Aowei mumbled in a low voice as the demon opened its mouth.

However, just as the demon tried to take a bite of Tian Aowei's face, a cold voice resounded from the room behind them.

"The stench of a demon... How unpleasant."

The door behind Tian Aowei and his wife suddenly flew open, and Tian Chenyu appeared from the room with a sword in his grasp, stabbing the demon right in its mouth.

After sticking his sword in the demon's face, Tian Chenyu kicked the demon in its stomach, sending it flying.

"It's dangerous here. You two should leave." Tian Chenyu said to his parents without looking at them.

"C-Chenyu?!" They stared at him with shocked looks on their faces.

Tian Aowei quickly snapped out of his daze and picked up his wife before running away.

"W-Wait! We cannot leave him with the demon! He'll die!" His wife shouted.

However, Tian Aowei ignored his wife and continued to carry her away from the scene.

The moment Tian Chenyu's parents left, the demon got back to its feet and stared at Tian Chenyu while baring its sharp teeth at him.

"A mere mortal! How dare you!" The demon roared before running at him.

Seeing the demon running at him, Tian Chenyu's hands and legs began to tremble uncontrollably.

However, he quickly regained control over his body, swinging the sword in his grasp at the incoming demon.

Due to its arrogance, the demon didn't even bother to block Tian Chenyu's strike and allowed him to sever its arm.

"Useless! It's useless! Even if you cut me into a million pieces with that sword, I will fully recover within seconds like nothing ever happened!" The demon laughed madly as Tian Chenyu severed its other arm.

"Why don't we put that to the test?" Tian Chenyu said in a calm voice.

He then severed the demon's legs.

"I told you, it's useless!" The demon continued to laugh.

However, it stopped laughing a few moments later when its limbs still hadn't recovered.

'W-What's going on?! Why isn't my body recovering?!' The demon was puzzled, but it didn't panic— at least not yet.

It turned to look at its severed arms and legs, and to its absolute shock, its limbs had suddenly turned into stone!

"W-What is the meaning of this?! What did you do to me?!" The demon roared at Tian Chenyu, who was standing in front of it and looking down on it like it was trash.

"What did I do? Nothing much. I simply sealed your body, preventing it from regenerating... I think. This is actually my first time doing something like this, so I am really glad that it's working as I'd thought."

"Y-You sealed my body and my ability to regenerate? I-Impossible! There's no way humans could have such power! Who are you?!"

"I am the one who will be hunting down every single demon in this world until there are none of you left. I am the one who will put an end to this era of demons terrorizing humans. I'm your— demons' worst nightmare. I am Tian Chenyu!" Tian Chenyu said with a cold expression on his face.

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Chapter 886 - This Is Just the Beginning

The demon stared at Tian Chenyu with a stunned face after hearing his introduction.

But after a moment of silence, it suddenly burst out laughing, "Hahaha! You will hunt us down?! Hahaha! This is the funniest joke I have heard all century!"

After laughing for a good moment, it suddenly stopped laughing and proceeded to glare at Tian Chenyu with a threatening gaze.

"Who the fuck do you think you are, human?! I don't know what trick you used to prevent my body from healing, but I doubt it'll last for long! And even if you take away our regeneration temporarily, you still won't be able to kill us!"

"You're right." Tian Chenyu responded after a moment of silence.

"I don't have the means to kill you efficiently for now, but I will eventually find a way. Until then... I will just keep you sealed."

"Keep dreaming! Humans will forever be dominated by demons! You will forever remain as our livestock! It has been that way for thousands of years now! It won't suddenly change because you learned some new tricks!"

"Hahaha!" Tian Chenyu suddenly started laughing.

"What's so funny?!" The demon growled.

"I can't believe I used to be so afraid of demons. If only I had realized this earlier... Realized how truly pathetic demons are..."

"Anyways, before I seal you for good, I have a question for you. Do you know of any one-horned demons? It has a black horn on the right side of its head, and the horn has this weird zigzagging structure."

"If you tell me, I just might spare you."

"Hahaha! Go fuck yourself, you damn livestock!" The demon laughed in response.

"Is that so?" Tian Chenyu closed his eyes and took a deep breath.

"I still haven't come up with a good name for this technique yet, but what's the point of overthinking it? Let's just call it... Demon Sealing Strike."

Once he opened his eyes, Tian Chenyu brandished the sword in his grasp at the demon, decapitating the demon's head from its limbless body.

Shortly after the demon's head fell to the ground, its body and head turned into stone, coming fully sealed.

After sealing the demon, Tian Chenyu fell to his knees, and his body began trembling again.

He looked at his hands that were shaking nonstop.

'I did it... I have defeated a demon... I am no longer powerless...'

Tears flowed from his eyes, as he's been waiting for this moment for over 20 years.

However, he wasn't satisfied just yet. In fact, he was far from satisfied.

"This is just the beginning..." Tian Chenyu narrowed his eyes on the sealed demon.

"Now then... There should be two more demons rampaging in this city..."

After taking a deep breath, he stood back up and started making his way towards the exit.

"C-Chenyu!"

His mother suddenly appeared and embraced him.

"Are you okay?! Are you hurt?! What happened to the demon?!" She asked him.

"The demon? I took care of it."

"Y-You took care of it? How is that possible? You're just a mortal. You have never cultivated before... No mortal can possibly fight a demon, much less defeat it!" Tian Aowei appeared and said.

"You don't have to believe me. You can take a look at the demon yourself. It's right over there. Don't worry, it won't be able to harm you. In the meantime, I have two more demons to take care of, so if you don't mind, I'd like to excuse myself."

"W-What?! You plan on fighting the other demons as well?! That's too reckless! I won't let you go!" His mother embraced him even harder, refusing to let him go.

"I'm sorry, mother, but I have to go. This is the only reason I woke up from my coma, after all." Tian Chenyu said as he escaped her grasp.

"Chenyu..."

After Tian Chenyu left, his parents went to look at the sealed demon.

"Heavens... Is this really the same demon that attacked us just now? It... turned into stone..." Tian Aowei stared at the demon that had all of its limbs and head severed with a shocked face.

"D-Did Chenyu really do this...? How in heaven's name did he...?" His mother mumbled in a dazed voice.

"I guess he didn't spend 20 years in solitude for nothing..." Tian Aowei sighed.

After leaving his home, Tian Chenyu followed the demons' stench until he encountered the second demon.

When he arrived, it was chewing on the leg of a child.

The demon glanced at Tian Chenyu when it noticed his presence, and it spoke, "I'll eat you next, so stand there and wait for me. If you dare run, I will make your death more painful—"

However, before it could even finish its sentence, Tian Chenyu kicked the rock beside his feet, sending it flying at the demon and hitting it right in the face.

The demon stopped chewing for a moment before tossing away the half-eaten leg in its grasp and turning to look at Tian Chenyu.

After swallowing, it spoke in a grim voice, "How dare you, livestock... You're fucking dead!"

The demon started running at Tian Chenyu with its mouth wide open and dripping with saliva and blood.

Seeing this, Tian Chenyu took a deep breath before confronting the demon with his sword.

"Hahaha! What do you hope to achieve with that cheap sword?!" The demon laughed as it clawed at Tian Chenyu with its sharp fingers while taking all of his sword strikes head-on with its body.

'W-What's going on? Why is my body feeling stiff?' The demon wondered as it continued to attack Tian Chenyu.

However, by the time the demon realized what was happening to its body, it was already too late.

"What is this?! What did you do to my body?!" The demon roared at Tian Chenyu as it laid before him with most of its body turned into stone.

But instead of answering its question, Tian Chenyu asked, "Do you know any demons with a single zigzagging horn on the right side of its head?"

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Chapter 887 - Tian Chenyu's Decision

Chapter 887 - Tian Chenyu's Decision

"A demon with a zigzagging horn?" The demon mumbled in a low voice.

After a moment of silence, a wide grin appeared on its face, and it said, "Now that you mention it, I might have seen a demon like that before. Why do you care? Oh, let me take a guess. Perhaps you lost someone valuable to this demon? Hahaha!"

"I see... So you don't know anything about this demon. Well, not that it really matters. I will eventually find it as I wipe you demons from this world, one by one."

Tian Chenyu flicked his arm the next moment, sending the demon's head into the air and completely sealing it with the Demon Sealing Strike.

'Two down, one more to go.'

Sometime later, Tian Chenyu followed the last demon's scent until he reached the other side of the city.

However, by the time he'd arrived, the demon had already erased six families from the city and was preparing to leave.

"Hey, where do you think you're going, you lowly demon?" Tian Chenyu approached the demon as it reached the city gates.

"What the fuck did you just call me, livestock?" The demon halted its movements and turned to look at Tian Chenyu with a grim expression.

"What's wrong? You don't like it? I think it's quite fitting."

"Die!"

The demon suddenly attacked him without any warning.

[Demon Sealing Strike!]

A powerful and threatening aura that the demon couldn't comprehend erupted from Tian Chenyu's body.

'What is this feeling? My skin is crawling. Is it because of his aura? I don't like this feeling one bit.'

This is the demon's first time experiencing such an eerie feeling, but it didn't understand why. After all, it's never experienced the feeling of fear before.

And because of its ignorance, the demon did not even bother to avoid Tian Chenyu's attacks.

'This feeling... It's becoming more intensive... Becoming more uncomfortable...'

The demon suddenly halted its movements.

'I... cannot move my body...?'

When it looked down, the demon could see that its right leg had completely turned into stone.

"What did you do to my body, livestock?! What did you do?!" The demon roared.

"How annoying. This is the third time I've heard such a question today." Tian Chenyu snorted.

"The third time?" The demon's eyes widened with shock upon realizing something.

"You... Don't tell me that you had..."

A wide smile appeared on Tian Chenyu's face as he spoke, "Don't worry, I took care of them before coming to you."

"YOU BASTARD! A MERE LIVESTOCK! HOW DARE YOU DEFY US —"

Tian Chenyu shoved his sword into the demon's mouth in the middle of its outcry.

"Shut up, you're too loud."

And without any hesitation, Tian Chenyu poured demon sealing aura into the demon's body through the sword stuck inside its throat.

Once the demon was completely sealed, Tian Chenyu began making his way back home, where his parents were anxiously waiting for him.

"Chenyu! You're fine!" His mother immediately went to embrace him.

"I'm sorry for making you worry."

"What happened to the other demons?" Tian Aowei asked him.

"I took care of them. They won't be able to hurt anyone else for a long time... I hope."

"You hope?" Tian Aowei raised his eyebrows.

"Anyways, let's sit down and talk. I have something I need to tell you guys."

"Y-You want to talk? Right now? Why don't you get some rest first? You seem tired." His mother said.

Tian Chenyu pondered for a moment before nodding, "Sure."

He then returned to his room to rest for the remainder of the day.

While Tian Chenyu rested, the entire city was in an uproar about the demons' invasion, and above all, they were confused by the outcome.

The three demons that invaded their city had somehow turned into stone, something that has never happened before. Nobody saw what happened because they were all hiding inside their homes, but news of the demons turning into stone began spreading throughout the city like wildfire, and it would eventually make its way to the nearby cities.

Once cultivators from outside the city heard of the rumors, they made their way to Tian Chenyu's city to see the sealed demons for themselves.

"Who did this to the demons?" *This chapter is updated by f r e e w e b n o v e l . c o m*

This question would become the most asked question in the city for the next few years.

Eventually, peak experts from all over the world would visit the city to study the sealed demons and to find the person responsible for the demons, as they believed that this person could help them fight the demons and stop their terror.

However, this would not happen until Tian Chenyu had long left the city.

The following day after Tian Chenyu sealed the three demons, he approached his parents and said to them, "Mother, father, thank you—thank you for everything that you've done for me."

"W-What's wrong, Chenyu? Are you okay?" His mother asked him, feeling that something was wrong about his behavior.

"I have made a decision—a decision that you might not support but must be done." Tian Chenyu said.

And he continued, "I have decided to erase all demons from this world, and in order to do that, I must leave home and go on a long, long journey. I don't

know how long it will take or if I will ever return, and I know that this will make you unhappy, but I must do this."

"E-Erase all demons from this world? Do you have any idea what you're saying, Chenyu? There's no way that's possible!" His mother exclaimed.

"Whether it is possible or not, we won't know until I try. Even if it's impossible, I still have to try." Tian Chenyu remained firm on his decision.

"No! I won't allow it! This family is already crumbling as it is! If you leave, it will truly be destroyed—"

"Dear." Tian Aowei placed his hand on her shoulder and shook his head.

"Chenyu is no longer a child. If he's decided on a path, it is our duty as his parents to support it, even if we cannot comprehend it."

"In fact, this might be the only way for his heart to heal."

"Even if you say that, he'll die! Are you really fine with letting him walk a path that's clear suicide?!"

"He won't die. I believe in him. He's already defeated three demons by himself, after all. If anyone can defeat the Demon Clan, it's him."

Tian Aowei then turned to look at Tian Chenyu and said, "Can you leave us alone for a bit? I will talk it out with your mother."

"Okay." Tian Chenyu didn't say anything else and left his parents alone.

Once they were alone, Tian Aowei began trying to convince his wife to let their son leave.

Many hours later, they went to see Tian Chenyu, who was patiently waiting for them in his room.

"We've come to a conclusion." Tian Aowei said.

"Chenyu... Here, take this." His mother suddenly handed him a silver ring.

Tian Chenyu didn't ask any questions and accepted it.

"It's a spatial ring. It's a treasure often used by cultivators to store their luggage while they travel. It'll make your traveling a lot more convenient."

"Does this mean..."

"Yes, I— we both approve of your journey." His mother nodded with a gentle smile on her face.

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Chapter 888 - The Beginning of an Everlasting Legend

"Thank you, father. Thank you, mother. I will not let you down." Tian Chenyu clenched the spatial ring in his grasp with teary eyes.

"Don't lose it, Chenyu. Since it was created for cultivators, it was extremely expensive. We'll probably have nothing but plain rice to eat for the rest of the month because of that ring." His father said in a joking tone.

And he continued, "Also, you don't need to feel bad about leaving us behind. You're leaving for a great cause. Go out there and make a name for yourself so that we can brag about our son to our neighbors."

"Your father is right, Chenyu. I was only thinking about myself before and didn't consider your feelings, so you don't have to worry about me. Although I would be lying if I said that I won't be lonely and sad with you gone, it's nothing I cannot handle."

Tian Chenyu nodded.

"I won't leave immediately, so until I leave, allow me to make up for the past twenty years as much as I can," he said a moment later.

Thus, Tian Chenyu began spending all of his time with his parents until the fateful day of his departure.

"Have you heard? The entire city is going crazy over the demons you defeated." Tian Aowei laughed as they ate dinner that night.

"I have this incredible urge to tell everyone that it was my son who did it, but I doubt anyone would even believe me."

"Father, mother, I should've told you this earlier, but you shouldn't reveal the truth to anyone. It could bring you trouble. The demons will also start looking for the one who's responsible sooner or later." Tian Chenyu warned them with a serious expression.

"Don't worry, we won't say anything. We're not that dumb."

A week later, Tian Chenyu finished packing for his journey and said his final goodbyes to his parents before leaving the city.

"Go make our ancestors proud, Chenyu." His father said after hugging him.

"We'll miss you very much. Make sure to send us letters whenever you can." His mother said as she hugged him.

"Goodbye, father. Goodbye, mother." He bid them farewell with teary eyes.

After leaving the city, Tian Chenyu walked to this massive graveyard that was located about ten miles away.

Once he found the gravesite he was looking for, Tian Chenyu knelt before it and placed a wreath made of white flowers onto the tombstone.

"I know I am a little late, but I couldn't bring myself to see you after what happened... until now. I hope you'll forgive me, Ai Rong."

Tian Chenyu proceeded to spend many hours talking to Ai Rong at her gravesite, telling her about his plans for the future and everything that he wanted but couldn't tell her before.

"Hey, Ai Rong, do you believe in reincarnation? I know this may sound silly, but I believe in it, and I believe that we will see each other again one day. p an da no v el I promise that no matter how long it takes that I will find you, and when I do, I will make you my wife— if you're willing to forgive me and still love me by then."

"And before I find you, there is something I must do. I must first cleanse this world of demons. I don't know how long it'll take or if it's even possible, but I will do my best."

"The next time we see each other, it will be in the flesh. I love you, Ai Rong. Until next time."

Once he was satisfied, Tian Chenyu stood up and took one last look at Ai Rong's tombstone before turning around and leaving the graveyard to go on his journey.

Unbeknownst to countless people, this was the beginning of an everlasting legend.

And shortly after Tian Chenyu left his home, he would make a name for himself by sealing demons wherever he went, but nobody would actually know his true identity until many years later.

"Yuan! We're ready!" Wang Ming's voice suddenly resounded from the backyard, waking Yuan from his daze.

He stopped playing his zither and responded, "I will be there in a minute."

After wiping the tears that had been dripping down his face for a while now, Yuan stowed Azure's zither in the closet and made his way to the backyard where the others were gathered with their weapons.

"Besides Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang, I believe this will be your first time seeing a demon. google p an da no v el It's going to be horrifying at first, and you might even feel like running away, but remember, as long as I am here, you'll be safe." Yuan said to them.

"Run away? I doubt it." Wang Ming said.

"Don't underestimate demons, Wang Ming. You'll understand what I mean when you see one." Yuan shook his head.

"Alright." He nodded.

Sometime later, the Manager arrived at their backyard while pushing a cart that was carrying a tall wooden box.

"Here's your demon." The Manager began glaring at Yuan the moment she arrived.

"Thank you, Liya."

"I thought I already told you to not call me by my name?" She frowned.

"Oh, really? I'm sorry, I must have forgotten. search p an da no v el " Yuan chuckled, which only irritated her even more.

He approached the wooden box a moment later and retrieved the demon from it.

"T-That's a demon?" Wang Ming swallowed nervously after seeing the demon's hideous appearance.

"If you're scared now, just wait until it is released from its seal." Yuan said with a smile.

"What are you going to do now?" The Manager asked him a moment later.

"Just watch."

Yuan carried the sealed demon with his Qi Manifestation, placing it in the middle of the training field.

[Demon Sealing Zone!]

He then created a Demon Sealing Zone that was around 75 meters in diameter with the demon at the center of it.

"Alright, everybody, I am going to give you a briefing on what's about to happen." Yuan gestured for the others to gather around him near the demon.

They swallowed nervously and approached Yuan and the ominous-looking demon.

Once everyone was gathered, Yuan began briefing them in a casual tone that made it seem like they were only going for a stroll in the park.

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Chapter 889 - Practice Tool

"Once I unseal the demon, the nine of you will attack the demon and try to seal it again. The stronger your demon sealing aura, the quicker you will seal the demon. Once you're all confident in fighting the demon together, I will be splitting you all into smaller groups."

"Eventually, I want you guys to be able to fight the demons by yourself." Yuan said to them.

"By ourselves?" Shi Lang swallowed nervously.

"One more thing. The demon will obviously be fighting back. As long as its attack won't cause any lethal damage, I won't stop it, so don't expect me to help you block every strike."

"I will give you all a couple more minutes to prepare before I unseal the demon."

"How are we going to do this?" Wang Ming asked the others.

"Who knows. Let's just attack it whenever we get the chance." Shi Lang shrugged.

"Yuan, we're ready." Xi Murong said to him sometime later.

"Alright. I am going to unseal the demon now. Brace yourselves."

Right before he unsealed the demon, Yuan wore a mask over his face.

This puzzled the others, but they didn't have the time to ask him any questions, as the demon was freed from its seal the next moment.

"I AM FINALLY FREE! AHAHAHA!" The demon immediately began laughing the moment it left its seal.

"F-Fuck..." Wang Ming and the others could feel all of their strength and the courage they'd built up leaving their body when they felt the demon's bloodthirsty aura and heard its chilling voice.

Their bodies trembled uncontrollably, and their hearts throbbed erratically, like they were on the verge of having a heart attack.

"What are you all doing?! Stop standing there and attack it!"

Someone suddenly shouted at them, but it wasn't Yuan.

Instead, it was Chu Liuxiang, who was the first to make a move.

After shouting at the others, she held her palms towards the demon and released a blast of demon sealing aura at it.

The demon stopped laughing after Chu Liuxiang's attack struck it right in its face, blowing half of its face away.

Once it recovered the next second, the demon turned to look at her and narrowed its eyes, "Humans? No... Demon Sealers! As if I'd let you seal me again after I just broke out of my seal!"

The demon roared before running at Chu Liuxiang.

Whoosh!

An arrow that was enchanted with demon sealing aura suddenly flew at the demon from behind and stabbed it right in the back of its head.

However, the demon ignored Meixiu's attack and continued to run at Chu Liuxiang.

"Stand back!" Li Jinxi suddenly appeared before the demon and fearlessly blocked its path to Chu Liuxiang.

She swung her large sword at it, but the demon avoided it with ease.

Wang Ming and the others also snapped out of their daze and began attacking the demon together.

"A bunch of weaklings! So damn annoying!" The demon roared.

However, there was not much it could do to fight back, as it was severely outnumbered nine to one.

After fifteen minutes of relentless attacking from the Demon Sealing Faction, the demon was finally sealed again.

Seeing that the demon was finally sealed, Wang Ming and a few others immediately fell on their butt and began gasping for air.

"What do you think? Fighting a real demon." Yuan asked them afterward.

"I'm exhausted— mentally. I didn't think there would be such a vast difference between a sealed demon and an unsealed one..." Shi Lang said.

"I did warn you." Yuan smiled.

"Anyways, take an hour to rest. I will split you all into two groups, and you'll fight the demon again then."

While the others rested, the Manager approached Yuan and began shouting at him, "You're using the demon as a practice tool? Are you insane? You said that you'd take care of the demon as soon as possible!"

"Calm down. I have the demon and the situation under control. It won't be able to leave my Demon Sealing Zone."

"Also, this training is necessary for them. After all, what will happen to this world if I suddenly die? If I train them, this world won't be hopeless without me. Of course, I don't plan on dying before I erase all demons from this world, but you never know what fate has planned for you."

"Anyways, do you want to join them? I can teach you demon sealing techniques so that you can also fight demons." Yuan suddenly suggested.

"You want me to..." The Manager looked at him with wide eyes.

"What's wrong? The Lord asked for my help because neither of you can kill demons, right? If that's the case..."

"It won't work." The Manager suddenly interrupted.

"Huh? What do you mean?"

"If I could learn demon sealing techniques, I would've learned them long ago." The Manager said.

"So you tried to learn demon sealing techniques with the Qi Family but failed, huh? Don't worry, I am different from the Qi Family. If you study under my instructions, even a mortal can—"

"I said it's impossible." The Manager said, and without explaining further, she turned around and walked away.

Yuan immediately began pondering in silence about the Manager's words.

'There's only one reason why someone cannot learn demon sealing techniques...'

'I see... so that's why...'

A profound smile appeared on his face when he realized the truth.

The Manager stared at Yuan with a frown on her face.

'Why is he smiling? Did he realize it? No, that's impossible... There's no way...' She thought to herself.

An hour later, Yuan split the Demon Sealing Faction into two groups.

"First group will be Chu Liuxiang, Li Jinxi, Xi Murong, and Hong Xiuquan. The second group will be everyone else." Yuan said.

"The first group will go first. Everyone else, you can wait outside the Demon Sealing Zone for your turn."

"Whenever you guys are ready."

Once the first group was ready, Yuan unsealed the demon again.

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Chapter 890 - Backlash

"What is the meaning of this, humans?!" The demon roared when it was unsealed for the second time.

"Nothing much. I just figured you could assist me in training my friends. If you can defeat my friends, I will let you walk free." Yuan said.

"You think I will help livestock like—"

"Demon Sealing Pulse!"

Chu Liuxiang shot a wave of demon sealing aura at the demon, creating a hole in its chest.

"YOU FUCKING LIVESTOCKS! HOW DARE YOU MESS WITH ME!?"

The demon released its loudest roar yet.

Its body suddenly began growing larger, and its killing intent soared.

It was enraged.

"The demon is enraged. It will now be much stronger than before, and it will also take more effort to seal." Yuan warned them.

"Demon Sealing Strike!"

Li Jinxi approached the demon and confronted it with her greatsword. Although there was still a hint of fear within her eyes, she was able to suppress it.

While Li Jinxi fought the demon, keeping its attention on her, Hong Xiuquan and Xi Murong would support her by attacking the demon from its blindspots.

As for Chu Liuxiang, she would attack whenever possible from afar.

'They have pretty good teamwork despite this being their first day fighting together.' Yuan thought to himself as he watched them fight.

'But they will need more than that to defeat the demon this time around.'

BANG!

Li Jinxi was suddenly sent flying by the demon's attack.

"Jinxi! Are you okay?!" Xi Murong shouted as he took over her spot.

"Yes, I am fine. I just wasn't expecting so much power from it. Looks like I will have to get a little serious as well."

Li Jinxi's body suddenly began emitting a red aura.

"T-That technique! She's using it now?! What if she goes on a rampage like before?!" Wang Ming exclaimed.

"She'll defeat both the demon and the others at this rate!" Shi Lang cried out loud.

"Yuan, you need to stop her before she goes crazy!" Wang Bingbing said to him.

"Huh? What's wrong with her?" Yuan asked.

"You don't remember what happened at the tournament? She will go crazy if she uses that technique for too long! When that happens, all hell will break loose! At least that's what her family told us before we left!"

"Really? It looked like she had complete control over it during the disciple examination." Yuan said.

"That's in a video game and this is real life! I'm sure you can do things in Cultivation Online that you can't do here, right?"

"Alright, I will stop her if things get out of hand. For now, let's just see where this goes. Don't forget, I stopped her during the competition." Yuan smiled.

"Okay."

Meanwhile, Li Jinxi continued to pressure the demon, deflecting all of its attack with her raw strength.

"Uhh... What should we do?" Hong Xiuquan turned to look at Xi Murong.

"Why are you asking me? There's nothing we can do when she's like that. We'll only get in her way. In fact, she might even attack us if we get too close." Xi Murong shrugged.

"Unbelievable... She's already fighting the demon all by herself... She's truly talented." Chu Liuxiang mumbled in a dazed voice.

About ten minutes later, the demons stopped moving, as it'd turned into stone.

Li Jinxi had managed to seal the demon all by herself.

"Wow, she really did it..." Wang Ming mumbled in awe.

However, Li Jinxi wasn't finished.

"Watch out!" Chu Liuxiang suddenly shouted.

"Huh?" Xi Murong turned around to see Li Jinxi running at him with her sword in the air, her eyes filled with bloodlust.

"I knew it! Yuan!" Wang Bingbing turned to look at him, but he was already on the move.

Clang!

Yuan appeared before Xi Murong to block Li Jinxi with the Empyrean Overlord.

"Wake up!"

Yuan swung his sword, sending Li Jinxi flying out the Demon Sealing Zone.

"Aaaah!" Li Jinxi roared, and her red aura started going even more out of control.

However, before she could cause any more harm to herself, Yuan used his movement technique to appear in front of her and gave her a good punch in the stomach, instantly knocking her unconscious.

After catching Li Jinxi's body, Yuan said to the others, "We'll stop here for today and continue our training tomorrow."

"Thank god..." Wang Ming sighed in relief after hearing such words.

"I'm going to bring Jinxi back to her room." Yuan said as he carried her like a princess.

"You're going to leave the demon out here just like that? That's insane!" The Manager approached him as he tried to leave.

"Don't worry, the demon won't go anywhere. It'll remain sealed for a week with the strength of Jinxi's demon sealing aura." Yuan said.

"Absolutely not! I will not leave here until you kill that demon!" The Manager exclaimed.

"Be my guest. We have plenty of empty rooms in our household." Yuan chuckled.

"Y-You...! Unbelievable!" The Manager stomped her feet in anger.

Sometime later, Yuan placed Li Jinxi on her bed so that she could rest.

However, right as he prepared to leave, he started hearing noises coming from behind, and it sounded like someone was groaning in pain.

"Jinxi? Are you okay? What's happening to you?" Yuan rushed back to her side when he noticed that she was soaked in sweat.

"It... hurts..." She muttered in a low voice.

"Is this a backlash from using her technique? This didn't happen before."

After pondering for a second, Yuan rushed out of the room to find someone from the Six Spiritual Families.

He quickly ran into Wang Bingbing.

"Something's wrong with Jinxi! She's sweating buckets, and she appears to be in pain!"

"What?! It must be due to the technique that she used earlier! Senior Li warned us about it. That she might experience some backlash if she used it."

"What should we do to calm her down?" Yuan then asked.

"I don't know. Senior Li didn't mention it, but I will immediately call her family."

Chapter 891 - Massage

"Hello?"

"Senior Li? It's me, Wang Bingbing."

"Oh, it's been—"

"This is an emergency, Senior Li! Li Jinxi, she's currently experiencing a backlash from using her weird technique that you warned us about!"

"What?! Why did that foolish child use that technique?!"

"It's a long story, but right now, I need you to tell me what we can do to calm her down!"

"Right. Her muscles right now should be pulsating, almost like there are worms wiggling inside her body. Can you see it?" Senior Li asked.

"Yes, I see it." Wang Bingbing said.

"This is the result of Li Jinxi enhancing her muscles far past their limits. In order to calm her down, you must relax her muscles. Massage her body and then let her body simmer in hot water until she's fully recovered. If you have any medical leaves around, soak them in the hot water for a better effect."

"Okay. Thank you, Senior Li. I will call you back once things calm down." Wang Bingbing said before closing the connection.

"Did you hear all of that?" She turned to look at Yuan.

"Yes, I heard him loud and clear. I will fill the bath with hot water. In the meantime, can you massage her body?" He asked her.

"I-I don't know how to do massages, but I can try... You just squeeze their muscles with strength, right?" Wang Bingbing swallowed nervously before she started massaging Li Jinxi's arms that felt incredibly weird.

"Yuan, I don't think this is helping! Her muscles feel incredibly stiff, like I am massaging rocks instead of muscles." Wang Bingbing called for help.

Yuan said, "Alright, switch with me. I will see what I can do."

After switching places with Wang Bingbing, Yuan pondered as he inspected Li Jinxi's condition.

'Her muscles feel like stones, huh? Let's try this...'

Yuan began massaging Li Jinxi's body starting with her arms.

"How do you feel?" Yuan asked her a few moments later.

"B-Better..." She uttered.

"Good, then this is working."

A few moments later, Wang Bingbing asked him from the bathroom, "Yuan, any results?"

"Yes, it's working. She's getting better."

"Really? I'll be with you in a minute!"

Once she was finished with filling the bathtub, Wang Bingbing returned to the bedroom to check on them.

"How are you doing this? I hope you're not using brute force..." She swallowed nervously when she saw how causally Yuan made it seem like massaging Li Jinxi.

"Of course not. I am not really using my fingers to massage her muscles. I am using my spiritual energy to guide her muscles instead— to loosen it."

"Where did you learn how to do such a thing?" Wang Bingbing asked him with great curiosity.

"Cultivation Online," he said with a smile.

Sometime later, once Yuan finished massaging Li Jinxi's arm, he moved to other parts of her body until all of her limbs were relaxed.

"Alright, I think she's ready for the bath." Yuan said.

"Wait..." Li Jinxi suddenly grabbed his hand.

And she continued, "Massage... here... as well..."

Using her free hand, Li Jinxi ripped her shirt right off her body, revealing her bare chest to them.

"Uhhh..." Yuan raised his eyebrows and turned to face Wang Bingbing.

"D-Don't worry, this is to relieve her pain. I will also be here, so there won't be any misunderstandings."

"Alright."

Yuan said nothing else and started massaging Li Jinxi's body.

About ten minutes later, Wang Bingbing carried Li Jinxi into the bathroom to soak in hot water.

"I will wait outside." Yuan said as they entered the bathroom.

"Thank you..." Li Jinxi mumbled in a low voice.

"Maybe you'll think twice before using that weird technique again." Wang Bingbing smiled.

"I don't understand... I was able to use it without any problems in Cultivation Online. I thought it would be fine if I started using it out here now, but..."

"Don't worry too much about it. I'm sure you'll eventually be able to use that technique without any backlash." Wang Bingbing said.

After spending about two hours soaking in the bathtub, Li Jinxi recovered from her backlash.

"How are you feeling?" Yuan asked.

"I am feeling fine. Thank you for the massage, and I'm sorry for causing you trouble. I won't use that technique again."

"Actually... I want you to continue using that technique. I want you to practice your control with that technique." Yuan said, dumbfounding them.

"Y-You want her to continue using that technique? But that would..." Wang Bingbing stared at him with wide eyes.

"No, she will only experience a backlash if she goes overboard with the technique. As long as she maintains control over it, she will be fine."

"Why? Why do you want me to...?" Li Jinxi asked with a puzzled face.

"You don't want to? Oh, I am not forcing you. If you don't want to master that technique, which will, without doubt, make you much stronger—"

"I will do it!" Li Jinxi quickly said.

"I want to become stronger. I want to be able to use that technique without feeling pain afterward. Can you help me?"

Yuan nodded, "I will help you to the best of my abilities, but it's not going to be easy. You might even experience more backlashes during your training. Are you prepared for that?"

"Yes, I am prepared. If I experience any backlashes, you'll be there to massage me, right?"

"Of course." He nodded.

"..."

Wang Bingbing witnessed their casual conversation with her mouth wide open.

'How can they say such shameless things to each other without being embarrassed about it?' She wondered inwardly.

"Get some rest."

Yuan and Wang Bingbing left Li Jinxi alone shortly after.

"I'm going to call Senior Li to let him know that everything is fine now." Wang Bingbing said.

"Alright. You should get some rest too. Your group will be fighting the demon first thing tomorrow morning, after all." Yuan said with a smile.

"I completely forgot about that..."

"I will see you later at dinner."

"Of course." Wang Bingbing nodded.

Chapter 892 - Manager's True Nature

Chapter 892 - Manager's True Nature

Before she even started cooking dinner, Meixiu approached Yuan and asked him, "You know the Manager has been standing in our backyard this entire time, right? I think she's guarding the demon. Maybe we should invite her for dinner?"

"I doubt she'll even want to join us, but I will ask her just in case."

"Okay, I will leave her to you. I will go prepare for dinner now."

Once Meixiu left, Yuan went to the training area to confront the Manager.

"You'll catch a cold if you stand out here for too long. Why don't you come inside and have dinner with us? Meixiu's a great cook."

The Manager slowly turned to look at him with a cold expression on her face, "I have an even better idea. Why don't you hurry up and kill the demon so that I can go back home and eat my own dinner?"

"Why are you so worried about the demon? I have already promised you that there won't be any problems. The demon is sealed, and I will use it to train my friends for the next few days. Once that is done, I will kill it and move onto the next demon."

"Why don't you use the other demons to train your friends? There are 11 demons in total. You can train for a total of 11 days if you use a demon once a day." The Manager then asked.

Yuan smiled and said, "We need to tackle this at a certain pace. They just had their first experience fighting a demon today. In fact, this is their first time seeing a real demon that's not sealed."

"If we rush this, it will only do more harm than good."

After a moment of silence from the Manager, she spoke in a grim voice, "The fact that you're taking this situation so lightly proves to me that you know nothing about demons or what they are truly capable of."

"I know nothing about demons?" Yuan couldn't help but chuckle at her claims.

"What's so funny? If you knew the true horror of demons, you wouldn't be acting so casually."

"There is nobody in this world that knows more about demons than me." Yuan said.

"Where does your confidence come from?"

"Just like how I don't really know anything about you or the Lord, you also don't know anything about me."

"Give me a few days. I will prove to you that I have the situation completely under control. In the meantime, why don't you relax a little and come eat dinner with us? If you waste Meixiu's effort and the food she cooked for you, I will tell everyone about your true nature."

"My true nature? What do you know about me?!" The Manager suddenly shouted at him.

A profound smile appeared on Yuan's face as he responded in a calm voice, "Qi Fang told me. You may act all serious and careful in public, but you're really just a lazy woman who'd rather lay in her bed all day watching television."

The Manager's face immediately flushed with redness after hearing his words.

"S-She told you that?! That good-for-nothing loudmouth! The next time I see her, I will definitely..."

"Let's go, Liya. I'm getting cold and hungry." Yuan said to her as he began making his way back to the house.

"How many times do I have to tell you to not call me by that name?" The Manager frowned.

Once Yuan left the scene, the Manager released a sigh of relief, 'He startled me for a second there. I really thought he knew about that...'

Sometime later, everyone gathered at the dining table for dinner.

"Where's the Manager?" Meixiu asked Yuan after they sat down.

"She..."

The door opened at this moment, and the Manager slowly walked into the dining room before taking a seat at the table with everyone else.

"Thank you for coming." Yuan smiled at her.

After dinner, Yuan said to everyone there, "I must say, you all performed much better than I'd anticipated today. At this rate, you'll all become expert demon sealers in no time."

"However, with that being said, I noticed some mistakes that some of you made. I will now tell you those mistakes, so listen up and try to learn from it."

"Wang Ming, I know demons are very ugly and hard to look at, but you must look at them while you're confronting one. I noticed that you tried to avoid eye contact with the demon as much as possible today. That will easily get you killed if you're fighting a demon alone."

"Shi Lang, that also applies to you. Your movements today are quite sluggish. Your movements during regular training are a whole level better compared to your performance today."

"Jinxi, you're too aggressive with your attacks. You use too much strength when you swing your sword. Remember, it's your demon sealing aura that

damages the demons, not your strength."

"Meixiu, you need to stop holding back. I know that it could be a little hard to shoot the demon with a bow and arrow when the others are fighting it at close range, but you subconsciously hold yourself back even when you have a clear shot."

"On the other hand, Lulu, you need to learn how to hold back. You're using too much energy even when it isn't necessary."

Yuan continued to speak until everybody that participated in the training today was lectured.

"Now that you all know what you did wrong, I want you to keep it in mind and learn from it."

"I must admit, Yuan, I never knew you were such a good teacher. Where'd you learn such a skill?" Wu Zao asked him after their lecture.

"I wouldn't call that teaching. I'm just pointing out what I saw, that's all. I don't qualify to be called a teacher." He shook his head.

"No need to be humble, Yuan. We know a good lecturer when we see one. You could easily become a top lecturer at the Jaded Garden if you worked there." Wang Ming said.

After talking with each other for a few more minutes and cleaning up the place, everyone but Yuan and the Manager retired to their rooms.

Chapter 893 - Explosion

"We have a fully furnished guest room if you really intend on staying here tonight." Yuan said to the Manager and pointed at a certain room down the hallway.

"I don't need any room." The Manager said, and she proceeded to leave the building, returning to the training area with the sealed demon.

"Does she really intend on staying out there the whole night? It makes me feel kind of guilty." Chu Liuxiang asked out loud as she looked at the Manager's lonely figure through the window in their room.

"Let her do as she pleases. It's not like I didn't offer her a room." Yuan said.

The following morning, after a light breakfast, everyone gathered at the training area.

"Since we stopped with the first group yesterday, the second group will start things off today."

"Meixiu, Wang Ming, Shi Lang, Wang Bingbing, and Wu Zao. You're up." Yuan said to them.

Once they were prepared after a short warmup, Yuan removed the seal on the demon for the third time.

"FUCKING LIVESTOCKS! HOW DARE YOU MESS WITH ME?!" The demon immediately became enraged the moment it came out of its seal.

"Let's go!"

Wang Ming was the first to act, followed by Shi Lang.

After Yuan's lecture yesterday, they focused on trying to suppress their fear towards the demon as they confronted it.

Of course, it was easier said than done, and they were still overwhelmed by fear for the first few minutes.

However, as they fought the demon, their fear began to reduce, allowing them to fight more efficiently.

Wang Ming's sword attacks were sharp and powerful. Shi Lang was incredibly precise with his spear.

The two of them danced beside each other in front of the demon to keep it at bay from the others, who would attack the demon from its blindspot.

Because of their near perfect teamwork, the demon could barely retaliate, and when it would try to retaliate, an arrow would appear from its blindspot and blow a hole in its face, halting its movements for a second, which is enough for the others to catch their breath and continue their onslaught.

After ten minutes of relentless effort from group two, the demon became sealed again.

"I'm exhausted." Wang Ming fell onto his butt afterward.

"Did you guys secretly practice together? I must say, your teamwork is almost impeccable." Yuan asked them.

"No, but if you spar enough with someone, you subconsciously predict their movements and instinctively react accordingly." Shi Lang said.

"Yes, and since we all lived in the same place, we all ended up training with each other." Wang Bingbing said.

"Furthermore, there are not many disciples within the Jaded Garden that could keep up with us, so we end up practicing with each other more than we like." Wang Ming sighed.

"I see... It makes perfect sense then." Yuan nodded.

After pondering for a moment, he asked them, "Do you guys feel confident enough to fight the demon by yourselves now? If you're not, we can continue fighting in smaller groups."

"Fighting the demon alone?" They all swallowed nervously at such a thought.

Seeing their reaction, Yuan smiled, "I guess it's still too early. After all, it's only the second day. Alright, you will continue fighting in groups, but since it's clearly too easy with your current numbers, I will split the group even smaller."

"The new first group will be Wang Ming, Xi Murong, and Meixiu."

"The second group will be Shi Lang, Wang Bingbing, and Lulu."

"The third group will be Wu Zao, Hong Xiuquan, and Li Jinxi."

After a short break, Yuan unsealed the demon and continued their training, and they would quickly realize how losing a single person in their group made it exponentially harder for them to fight the demon.

They were able to seal the demon without getting hurt before, but now they're all receiving minor injuries, and it took them twice as long to seal the demon with each group taking almost half an hour to seal the demon.

Sometime later, Wang Ming lost his balance for a split second after his attack was deflected, and the demon immediately took advantage of his moment of weakness and went straight for his neck without any hesitation.

'Shit!'

Death flashed before Wang Ming's eyes.

"Die, livestock!"

The demon's claw reached the skin on Wang Ming's neck and penetrated into his skin, but its entire body froze before it could really pierce his neck.

Wang Ming immediately distanced himself from the demon, and he could feel his own blood dripping down his neck afterward.

"T-Thank you, Yuan..." Wang Ming said in a trembling voice.

"The fight isn't over yet." Yuan said to him before removing the restrictions on the demon, allowing it to move again.

However, the demon didn't continue to fight.

Instead, it turned to look at Yuan.

"What did you just do to my body?"

"As long as you're within my Demon Sealing Zone. I have complete control over your body." Yuan calmly responded.

"D-Demon Sealing Zone?"

The demon had been so focused on fighting the others that it didn't even realize it was trapped inside the Demon Sealing Zone until now.

"I see..."

The demon appeared to realize its situation shortly after.

"If that's the case, I'd rather die than be a plaything for humans!"

The demon suddenly began expanding like a balloon, and its body also started burning like steel that just came out of the forge.

When Yuan saw this, he immediately shouted, "All of you, get away from the demon! It's going to explode!"

"What?!"

The others immediately distanced themselves from the demon.

Meanwhile, Yuan shrunk the Demon Sealing Zone until it was only a few meters in diameter.

Once the demon reached its limit, the crystal on its body shattered, causing its body to explode with intense spiritual energy.

The entire mountain shook for a brief moment after the explosion, but because of the Demon Sealing Zone that contained all of the impact, there was no real damage done by it and nobody was hurt.

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Chapter 894 - celestial Qi

"Yuan, you never told us that demons could just explode like that!" Shi Lang exclaimed afterward.

"Sorry, they rarely do that even in desperate situations so I forgot about it." Yuan said with an apologetic smile.

"What the demon just did is called a 'Core Detonation'. It's basically a suicide move that is very hard to stop and has the effects of a bomb. I didn't think it would kill itself so quickly, so I wasn't prepared for it. What a pity it only lasted for two days."

"With that being said, Liya, can you bring us the next demon?" Yuan turned to face her.

"Absolutely not! You almost blew up the entire mountain!" She immediately refused.

"That's an exaggeration. With that demon's strength, it would've blown away our house at most." Yuan said.

"Ridiculous! Why are you even training them?! What do you hope to achieve with just a few days of training?! There are only 10 demons left, and I doubt they are capable of fighting all 10 demons! Even if they can fight all 10 demons, it won't make any real difference! If it was so easy to train a demon sealer, there would be many more demon sealers in this world!"

After a moment of silence, Yuan spoke, "Yes, you're right. Out of the remaining 10 demons, they would only be able to fight two of them with the rest being way beyond their capabilities."

"However, you shouldn't underestimate my friends nor my training methods. Even a day's worth of training will benefit them enormously. In fact, it could even be a difference of life and death."

"I don't get it... Just where are you getting your confidence from?" The Manager sighed, feeling as though she was talking to a wall.

Of course, there was no way that the Manager could have known that in one of Yuan's past lives, he was the Divine Paragon, creator of the demon sealing techniques and the founder of the Demon Sealing Clan, where he trained tens of thousands of demon sealers.

"Trust me, this will only last for 2 more demons. After that, I will swiftly take care of the rest. I promise."

The Manager rubbed her temples for a good moment before speaking, "Fine. Two more demons. If you don't stop messing around with the demons after that, I will kill you. I promise."

"Thank you, Liya." Yuan smiled.

"Don't call... Forget it..."

Yuan then turned to look at the others and proceeded to lecture them about their mistakes.

"How do you feel, Wang Ming?" Yuan asked him afterward.

"I'm still a little shaken... If you hadn't stopped the demon, I would've been dead now." He sighed.

"I'm truly pathetic."

"Don't think like that. You're doing very well for a new demon sealer. In fact, most demon sealers won't be able to face a real demon without months of intense training. The fact that you could fight it without running away on your first day is very impressive."

"This goes for all of you. I'm actually very surprised that none of you ran away. Of course, I wouldn't have blamed any of you even if you did run away."

'After all, I was frozen from fear when I first encountered a demon...' He sighed inwardly.

"Anyways, let's take a break. We'll start our next training session in two days."

Sometime later, the Manager returned to the Lord to explain the situation to him.

"I see... So that's the real cause of the tremor just now. I thought it was another earthquake caused by the sealed demons. He's using the demons as a practice tool for the others... I must say, this is beyond my expectations. It's so bold that it's almost crazy." The Lord sighed.

"Should I stop him?"

"And how are you going to do that? You might have been able to defeat him when he first arrived at the mountain, but you won't stand a chance against him now."

"What? You think he's stronger than me? Is it because he can kill demons and I cannot? If I could use demon sealing techniques, I would also be able to kill them!" The Manager exclaimed.

"No, his strength far exceeds his ability to kill demons. Although very faintly, I could sense Celestial Qi from his body during his last visit."

"What?! Celestial Qi?! Impossible! He was born in this world! There's no way he could have Celestial Qi!" The Manager shouted in a voice of disbelief.

"It's true. I couldn't sense it from him before, but I sensed it very clearly during his last visit. He must have awakened his Celestial Qi somehow. Do you have any idea?"

The Manager pondered for a good moment before shaking her head, "The only thing I can think of is the incident that happened to him at the Qi Family, but it's highly unlikely. It was after our visit to the Qi Family that he started acting... differently."

"So something happened to him after he returned, huh? What could've happened in such a short time? I cannot even imagine."

Sometime later, the Lord spoke, "Anyways, continue monitoring him. We need to be certain that we can trust him."

"Okay..." The Manager nodded.

"What's wrong? You seem worried about something." The Lord suddenly asked.

"Actually... I might be overthinking this, but I have this feeling that he somehow knows of our secret." She sighed.

"What? How is that possible? Did you do something that could've revealed it?"

"No! I didn't say or do anything—"

The Manager suddenly stopped talking and held a dazed look on her face.

"I-I told him that I couldn't learn demon sealing techniques out of frustration... That's also around the time when I started having this feeling. T-There's no way he could've realized the truth just from that alone... right?" The Manager said in a worried voice.

"It's possible."

"I-I'm sorry..." The Manager sighed.

"What's done is already done. And we don't really know if he realized our secret or not. Just continue to monitor him, but don't try to probe his knowledge. You might end up telling him the truth, which would be quite comical if he doesn't actually know anything." The Lord said.

"Okay." The Manager nodded.

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Chapter 895 - Strength of the 11 Demons

After their training with the demon ended, Li Jinxi approached Yuan, who went to pick up the demon core left behind by the demon, and said to him, "I don't need to rest. I want to practice my technique."

"I like your enthusiasm, but you should rest today. You've already spent the entire morning fighting with the demon. You need to let your muscles rest before you start practicing that technique." Yuan said to her.

"Then tomorrow..."

"Yes, we'll start tomorrow."

"Okay."

"Do you have some kind of special training for her?" Chu Liuxiang asked him.

"Not really. I'm only there to make sure she doesn't hurt herself too much. After all, I'm the only one in this place who can stop her when she goes on a rampage." He said.

"I see... Anyways, I'm going to take a bath and practice my demon sealing technique some more. Want to join me in the bath?" She calmly asked him, almost as though it was a normal routine to bathe together.

"Sure." Yuan nodded his head without hesitation.

Meanwhile, inside a luxurious restaurant somewhere in Spirit Heaven, the Sect Master of the Universal Music Academy, Sun Hao, sat before the

Patriarch of the Gu Family.

"It's been a while, Patriarch Gu. I hope your family has been well." Sun Hao greeted.

"Indeed, it's been a few years. My family is doing well. I hope my nephew is not causing any troubles in your sect. If he is, don't hesitate to tell me. I will give him a good scolding."

The two of them laughed for a good moment.

"Anyways, I heard you have some information on the people that robbed my Gu Family. Although it happened in the Lower Heaven, it is still a fact that they are a Gu Family. No matter where it occurred, I cannot allow such insolence towards the Gu Family."

"Indeed. The person responsible for robbing your Gu Family is someone named 'Yuan', is that correct?"

"That's the information we had received from the Lower Heavens." Patriarch Gu nodded.

"Well, I happened to meet that bastard a couple of days ago when he severed my arm." Sun Hao pointed at his missing left arm.

"What?" Patriarch Gu's eyes widened with surprise.

"I heard about what happened at the disciple examination. It was a tragedy. What a coincidence that the person who harmed you also happened to be the same person that robbed my Gu Family. However, it makes sense. Truly fitting of someone so barbaric and disrespectful."

"Don't worry, Sect Master Sun. I will make him pay for his crimes. I had only intended to imprison him for life, but I will now add torture to his punishment. In fact, I will remove his limbs and send them to you as a gift."

"That sounds like music to my ears." Sun Hao laughed merrily.

"Then Sect Master Sun, do you happen to know where he is currently located?" Patriarch Gu suddenly asked.

"Unfortunately, I do not know where he is currently located, but I know where and how you can find him." Sun Hao said.

And he continued, "That bastard will be heading to the Stairway to Heaven soon. You will find him at the site, or you can surround the area and wait for him to show up."

"The Stairway to Heaven? He's planning on challenging it? Is he a Spirit King?" Patriarch Gu showed a look of surprise.

"No, he's a peak Spirit Lord, but you shouldn't underestimate him. In fact, treat him as though you're fighting a Spirit King. You will need all of your experts if you want to deal with him, and he most likely won't be alone." Sun Hao said, purposefully not revealing to Patriarch Gu that Yuan had managed to defeat 6 Sect Masters of the Seven Spirit Academies all by himself, and it was an overwhelming defeat for them.

"Yes, I heard that he was traveling in a small group the last time, and there is even a Spirit King amongst them. The other Gu Family said that the Spirit King had the appearance of a little girl."

"A little girl? There was a little girl with that bastard at the disciple examination. I didn't pay any attention to her due to the circumstances. To think that she was actually a Spirit King..." Sun Hao said.

The two of them continued to chat with each other over some food and tea.

About two hours later, Patriarch Gu returned to his family.

After spending two days preparing for their mission, Patriarch Gu and over a thousand people from the Gu Family started making their way towards the Stairway to Heaven.

Of course, this alarmed the neighboring cities and sects, and they wondered if the Gu Family was going to war with such incredible military power.

The following day, the Manager returned to the Demon Sealing Faction's household with another demon.

"This demon looks weaker than the previous one." Wang Ming said after looking at the demon's appearance.

It was smaller and thinner than the last demon, after all.

"Don't let its appearance fool you. This demon is three levels stronger than the last demon. The last demon only had the strength of a peak Spirit Warrior cultivator. This one is around third level Spirit Master."

"T-Third level Spirit Master? That's as strong as the strongest cultivators in our families..." Wang Bingbing swallowed nervously.

"By the way, the next demon is around the fifth level." Yuan suddenly said.

"F-Fifth level?! Can we even fight that thing?!" Hong Xiuquan exclaimed.

"It's not going to be easy, but it's possible." Yuan nodded.

"Out of curiosity, what about the rest of the demons? There are a total of 11 demons, right?" Wu Zao asked.

"Three of them have the strength of a peak Spirit Master. Two of them are between the third level and fourth level of Spirit Grandmaster. Two more at the sixth and seventh level of Spirit Grandmaster. As for the last one... It has the strength of a 2nd level Spirit Lord."

"S-Second level Spirit Lord? What's your cultivation again, Yuan?" Wang Ming asked him in a nervous tone.

"Fifth level Spirit Grandmaster." He calmly responded.

"What?! You're six whole levels below the strongest demon! Are you sure that you can defeat it?"

"Of course." He confidently responded.

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Chapter 896 - Not Created for Humans

"Don't worry, it's just 6 levels. I have fought demons an entire realm stronger in Cultivation Online." Yuan gave him a confident thumbs up.

"But that's Cultivation Online, where you are much more powerful and have more resources to deal with demons..." Wang Ming sighed.

Sometime later, Yuan said, "Anyways, we'll begin training the day after tomorrow. I suggest you take this time to familiarize yourself with the demon. It will also have a much stronger aura than the previous demon, so prepare yourself mentally as well."

After their briefing, Li Jinxi and Yuan went to another part of the training area, where they would not disturb the others with their training.

"Go ahead and use that technique whenever you're ready. However, don't just activate it. I want you to slowly increase your own strength using the technique. Remember, we're training on your control right now."

Li Jinxi nodded, and she closed her eyes.

After taking a deep breath, she began using her technique.

At first, her body would emit a small amount of killing intent, and it would steadily increase.

However, after a few moments, almost as though she lost control, the red aura began expanding rapidly.

Eventually, Li Jinxi completely lost control, and she started going on a rampage.

Her eyes snapped open, revealing her crimson eyes that flowed with killing intent.

And she started attacking Yuan with her sword.

"Calm down. You can regain control." Yuan didn't immediately knock her out and tried to calm her down.

A few minutes later, without any success, Yuan decided to knock Li Jinxi unconscious.

After catching her falling body, he gently laid her on the ground.

"This is going to be more problematic than I'd anticipated..." He sighed in a low voice.

Li Jinxi would wake up shortly after.

"Do you feel any pain?" He asked her.

"No, I am fine. Let's continue." Li Jinxi said.

Thus, they continued to train until Li Jinxi started experiencing backlash an hour later.

When that happened, Yuan carried her into her room and began massaging her body.

"Sorry for the inconvenience..." She apologized to him while she soaked in medicine.

"Don't worry, I don't think it's bothersome. By the way, can you tell me more about the technique? If I understand it better, perhaps I can figure out how to train you."

After pondering for a moment, she nodded, "Wait until I am finished."

"Sure."

An hour later, Li Jinxi emerged from the bathtub and left the bathroom while still soaking wet.

"You'll catch a cold like that." Yuan smiled.

"I have never caught a cold before," she calmly said.

Then she walked to her closet and retrieved a wooden box from inside.

"Here."

She handed the box to Yuan afterward.

Yuan raised his eyebrows and opened the box to find a scroll inside.

"What's this?"

"The technique," she calmly responded.

"You mean the actual technique? Isn't this supposed to be your family's secret technique? Are you sure you want to hand it to me? You should consult with your family first..." Yuan said in a baffled voice.

He didn't expect Li Jinxi to hand him the entire technique.

"It's fine. Nobody in the family can use the technique, anyway." She calmly nodded.

"That's not the point." Yuan smiled.

"It's really fine. I won't tell my family," she said.

"Alright, I will borrow it then."

Yuan returned to his room shortly after.

After returning to his room, Yuan began studying Li Jinxi's mysterious technique.

'There's no name for this technique?' Yuan realized at glance that the technique was a nameless one.

About an hour later, Yuan placed the technique down and started to ponder.

'I see... It's no wonder why most people cannot learn this technique. The strain it puts on one's body is simply ludicrous. In fact, this technique... It wasn't created for humans...'

Yuan became even more impressed by Li Jinxi after realizing this fact.

'I'm surprised she managed to learn this technique. But this begs the question... Who is this technique made for? Magical beasts? Divine Beasts? And how did the Li Family acquire this technique?'

Once he understood the technique, Yuan returned to Li Jinxi, who was resting in her bed.

"Come inside." Li Jinxi said after hearing his knock on the door.

"Hey, I am finished with the technique, so I am here to return it. I learned a few things about this technique that you should be aware of." Yuan said as he placed the scroll on the desk beside her desk.

"You're finished with the technique already? It's only been an hour." She stared at him with a baffled look on her face as she sat up on her bed.

'She's still naked?' Yuan thought to himself after seeing Li Jinxi's appearance when the blankets moved.

He then spoke, "Yes, I have a lot of questions too, but first, you should know the true nature of this technique."

"This nameless technique... It wasn't made for humans."

"Huh?" Li Jinxi raised her eyebrows.

"Not made for humans? Is that why nobody else in my family could learn it? But how come I can learn it? Does this mean... I'm not human?" Li Jinxi looked more curious and fascinated than terrified at the possibility that she wasn't human.

"No, you're definitely human. The reason you're able to learn the technique is due to your unique physique. I noticed this when I massaged your body, but your muscles and bones are naturally beyond human capabilities, which allows your body to endure much more stress than normally capable. However, since you're human, you won't be able to fully utilize the technique's full capabilities— at least not in your current state."

"I see... Is this also why I have backlashes?" Li Jinxi then asked.

"Yes." He nodded.

"Then what should I do?"

"Since it's related to your physique, you must continue to strengthen your body. I believe that will be your fastest way to master this technique. The next is your control. As long as you can control the technique so that it doesn't exceed your limits, you won't experience any backlashes."

"But I have been doing that since I started cultivating," she said.

"Yes, but have you ever been pushed to your absolute limits?" He asked.

"Pushed to my limits...?" Li Jinxi raised her eyebrows in a questioning manner.

Chapter 897 - Training

"Yes. Have you ever been pushed to the point where you could not even lift a single finger? Have you ever been so exhausted that you thought you'd die by running out of breath? Have you ever risked your life in training?" Yuan asked.

Li Jinxi pondered for a moment before shaking her head, "No, not really."

"You can achieve immense growth in a short period of time if you continue to push yourself to your very limit every day. Of course, this could actually damage one's body, but this only applies to ordinary people. Jinxi, you have an amazing body—a physique blessed by the heavens. If anyone should train in such a manner, it should be you."

"However, it's not going to be easy. You will experience intense pain. Hell, you might even die."

"I want to do it." Li Jinxi responded without hesitation.

"Even if you might die?"

She nodded.

Yuan smiled. Although nobody knows about it, he'd almost died hundreds of times inside his room during his 20 years of seclusion. There were times when he wanted to quit and sleep eternally, but he would always get back up and train until he was at death's door.

But because of his insane and reckless training, he was able to acquire the strength to defeat demons in such a short time.

"How does your body feel right now?" Yuan asked her a moment later.

"A little sore, but that's it."

"Good. Get dressed and meet me in the training area. We're going to continue your training."

"Yes!"

Sometime later, they returned to the training area.

"Use the nameless technique and attack me. I won't just be avoiding and defending this time."

Li Jinxi nodded and activated the nameless technique, causing her bloodlust to reappear.

However, before she could even make a move, Yuan suddenly dashed forward and threw a powerful punch at her face.

Li Jinxi subconsciously blocked the attack with her sword, but she was still sent flying by the impact.

'So strong!'

"What are you doing?! Hurry up and focus! Fight me! Try to kill me!" Yuan shouted as he approached her again.

Li Jinxi clenched her teeth and started attacking him with the intention to kill.

However, Yuan suddenly released his killing intent, halting her movements for a brief second.

Yuan used this chance to connect his fist with her stomach, sending her flying for a second time.

After stabilizing herself, Li Jinxi immediately puked out everything she ate for breakfast.

She lifted her head a moment later to look at Yuan, who was slowly approaching her with an immense amount of killing intent flowing from his body.

Her entire body trembled in fear. For the first time in her life, she was fearing for her life.

"Get up! You will never achieve your full potential with such half-assed effort!" Yuan shouted at her, snapping her out of her daze.

"Aaaaah!" Li Jinxi stood up and released a war cry before running at him again.

"What the hell are they doing?" The Manager watched them from a distance with a puzzled face.

She thought they were training at first, but it looked too brutal to be training, and Yuan was pummeling Li Jinxi like she had killed his family.

Due to the loud nature of their training, the others also noticed the commotion in the training area, and they were all shocked by what they saw.

"Holy shit! What's happening?! Why are they going at each other's throat?!" Wang Ming asked the others.

"I'm not sure... Should we stop them and ask for an explanation?" Wang Bingbing said.

"They're probably training." Chu Liuxiang said.

"You call that training? It looks like a one-sided beatdown to me." Shi Lang said.

"God... I have never seen Li Jinxi in such a beaten state before... She looks like she's on the verge of death." Xi Murong mumbled in a dazed voice.

In the end, nobody went to stop them. They believed in Yuan and Li Jinxi—that they had a good reason to be fighting each other in such a manner.

The training lasted for three whole hours, stopping when Li Jinxi was covered in her own blood and completely unconscious.

Of course, Li Jinxi had lost consciousness a couple of times during the three hours, but they only lasted for a brief moment, and she would continue to train immediately after waking up.

As Yuan carried her seemingly lifeless body back to the house, everyone rushed to him.

"What the hell happened, Yuan?" Wang Ming was the first to ask.

"Hm? We were only training." He calmly said.

"Training? It looked like you wanted to kill her..." Shi Lang said.

Yuan smiled and said, "I will explain everything to you after I get her cleaned up."

"I will help you." Meixiu said.

"Okay. Thank you."

After Yuan brought Li Jinxi back to her room, Meixiu helped wash her body.

Sometime later, after putting Li Jinxi in her bed, Yuan returned to the others and explained the situation to them.

"The technique she had been using wasn't created for humans? Wow... that's unexpected. I never knew that such a thing even existed..." Wu Zao said.

"I get that you're trying to push Li Jinxi to her limit, but that would be pointless if she becomes bedridden for the next week, right?" Wang Ming asked.

Yuan smiled and said, "She'll be fine. In fact, she'll wake up tomorrow like nothing happened. This is all because of her unique physique."

"Also, I don't know if you noticed this or not, but Jinxi was able to use her nameless technique throughout our entire training without experiencing any backlash."

"N-Now that you mention it!" Their eyes widened upon this realization.

"How did you do it?" Wang Bingbing asked.

"It's simple. I used only my fists for a reason. Everytime I punch her body, it would release some of the built up tension in her muscles, allowing her to continue using the technique without reaching her maximum threshold as quickly." Yuan explained.

"I see..."

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Chapter 898 - Understanding the Nameless Technique

Sometime later, Yuan returned to his room while the others returned to their own training.

Li Jinxi woke up the following morning with an incredible headache and feeling like she'd been hit by a truck recently.

'Am I... still alive...?' She mumbled in a dazed voice.

It wasn't clear to her at first, but her memories of yesterday's training eventually resurfaced.

'Ahh... He was really ruthless yesterday... I have never been beaten like that... ever...'

A slight smile appeared on her face without her awareness.

Knock *Knock*

"It's me. Are you awake?" Yuan's voice suddenly resounded.

"Yes, come inside."

Yuan entered the room the next moment.

"How are you feeling?" He asked her.

Li Jinxi turned to look at Yuan and said with a bittersweet smile, "My body hurts like hell..."

"I might have gone too far for your first session. Sorry."

"No, I needed that. I have never suffered such a defeat before. It really opened my eyes."

"Do you wish to continue?" Yuan suddenly asked.

"Of course." Li Jinxi immediately responded without any hesitation in her voice.

"You'll wake up everyday like this, you know?"

"As long as I can become stronger."

"..."

After a moment of silence, Yuan asked, "Why are you so desperate to acquire strength?"

"You might not believe me, but I really don't have any motivation— at least I didn't until very recently. I enjoy fighting and improving myself. It's as simple as that." She calmly responded.

"I see... Then what is your motivation now? You have one now, right?"

Li Jinxi did not immediately answer.

She slowly got off the bed and stood on her feet despite the pain coursing through her body.

She then walked to stand in front of Yuan.

"You're my motivation now. I want to defeat you."

Yuan smiled and said, "It's not going to be easy."

"I know, but I won't stop training until I defeat you... no matter how long it'll take."

And she continued, "Go wait for me in the training area. I will be there in a bit."

"You want to train with your body like that? That's reckless."

"I can handle it," she said.

However, Yuan shook his head and said, "Go soak in some medicine first. I'll meet you in the training area in a few hours."

"Okay..."

While Li Jinxi went to soak in medicine, Yuan returned to his own room.

He then took a seat on the floor in the lotus position and took a deep breath.

'Even though they are different techniques, they function almost the same. I wonder if I will be able to control that golden aura if I deepen my understanding with Li Jinxi's nameless technique?'

In just a few moments, a red aura began appearing around Yuan's body.

Although he'd learned Li Jinxi's nameless technique, he doesn't have any intentions to use it. After all, he was only doing this to gain a better understanding for the technique.

Furthermore, his golden aura was vastly superior to the nameless technique.

'I have only absorbed two thousand years worth of Tian Chenyu's memories right now, but there is nothing about the golden aura in these memories. Just how long did Tian Chenyu live? When does he learn to use the golden aura?'

'However, there's no need to be impatient. I have already managed to activate it once. I will eventually be able to control it.'

Yuan would continue to study the nameless technique for the next few hours until he met up with Li Jinxi in the training area, where he would proceed to beat her until she was at the verge of death.

"How long are you two going to train like this?" Meixiu asked him as she washed Li Jinxi's bloody figure.

"I'm not sure, but it'll probably be for a while. You don't have to clean her if you don't want to. I can do it by myself. You're probably better off using this time to train yourself, after all." Yuan responded from outside the bathroom.

"No, I can do this. It doesn't take that much time, and it's not like I can let you wash the body of another woman..." Meixiu said with a slightly rosy face.

Yuan smiled and said, "Don't worry, I won't do anything I am not supposed to do to her. I already have you and Lulu, after all."

The redness on Meixiu's face immediately deepened, and she spoke, "T-That's not what I am worried about!"

Sometime later, Meixiu left the bathroom with Li Jinxi still unconscious in her arms.

"Thank you, Meixiu." Yuan said to her as she placed Li Jinxi's body on the bed.

"You should go easier on her, Yuan. It feels weird seeing you beating on a young lady, even if she's someone like Li Jinxi."

Yuan chuckled, "I can't help it. Ordinary training methods won't work on her. And after realizing how much talent she has, it makes me want to see her full potential."

Meixiu sighed, "You've really changed, Yuan."

"Huh? What do you mean?"

"Not long ago, you didn't even know the difference between a man and a woman. Now look at you. You're a competent teacher who has trained even an entire family of demon sealers."

"Your demeanor has also changed. It pained me to even look at you before because you were always depressed, but you're now brimming with confidence."

"If Yu Rou could see you now, I doubt she would even recognize you."

"Yu Rou, huh... Meixiu, this might be a weird question, but who do you prefer? The old me or the new me?" Yuan faced her with a serious look on his face.

"That's not a fair question, Yuan. It puts me in an awkward position. It's not a question that I can answer. However, if I have to be honest, I like how we can talk with each other while being on the same page, something that was not really possible back then. For example, the words 'I love you' would have a different meaning if I said it to the old you and the current you. Do you understand?"

Yuan chuckled, "Yes, I understand. I am well aware of how naive I was back then, and I'm sorry for all of the inconveniences it caused you."

Meixiu shook her head while blushing.

"Anyways, are you free now?" Yuan suddenly asked her.

"Besides training, I don't have anything else—"

Before she could even finish her sentence, Yuan picked her up and carried her like a princess.

"Y-Yuan?!"

"I want to thank you properly for helping me today. Let's go to your room." Yuan smiled.

"O-Okay..." Meixiu immediately understood the meaning behind his words and nodded in a bashful manner.

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Chapter 899 - New Product

After carrying Meixiu to her room, Yuan locked the door behind him and laid her on the bed.

Once they were fully prepared, they entangled their naked bodies together and began moving passionately with each other.

Two hours passed in the blink of an eye.

"Speaking of Yu Rou... It should be her birthday soon, right? I stopped paying attention to the dates long ago." Yuan said as he laid on the bed with Meixiu resting her head on his arm, feeling incredibly refreshed and relaxed.

"Her birthday is next month. In 17 days to be exact." Meixiu said without needing to think.

"We should give her a visit." Yuan then said.

"What about the demons?"

"I'll take care of them long before then." Yuan smiled.

"Then do you have any idea what you want to give her?"

"No, I was going to ask you for advice. What do you think she'll like? It's been forever since I last celebrated her birthday."

"I think she'll be happy no matter what you give her."

"I know, but that's not fun. I need to give her something grand— something worthy of my precious little sister."

Sometime later, Meixiu got dressed and left to prepare for dinner.

At dinner, to everybody's surprise, Li Jinxi showed up.

"Are you sure you should be moving around right now?" Wang Ming asked her.

"I'm fine," she calmly replied.

"My god, it took you an entire day to wake up yesterday. You're progressing a little too fast, don't you think?" Shi Lang mumbled in a dazed voice.

"I have a good teacher," she said as she turned to look at Yuan.

"How do you even endure such beating? Are you perhaps... a masochist?"

Li Jinxi immediately glared at the person who just spoke, Xi Murong, with a dangerous gaze.

"I-I am just joking..." Xi Murong swallowed nervously. Even in Li Jinxi's current state, he would still lose to her in a fight.

"Your jokes are getting worse and worse," she sneered.

"Sorry..."

After dinner, everyone but Meixiu returned to their rooms to rest.

"Where are you going so late at night?" The Manager asked after noticing her.

"T-The convenience store," she hastily replied.

The Manager raised her eyebrows in a questioning manner, but she didn't actually ask any questions.

'Even though the store is open 24/7, there's no need for her to go there now... Oh well, it's none of my business.'

The Manager calmly turned around and walked to the guest room.

Meixiu sighed in relief and left the building shortly after.

Sometime later, she entered the convenience store.

"Welcome."

A new woman that Meixiu did not recognize was at the counter today.

"Hello. Where is the other worker?" She asked.

"She just finished her shift about an hour ago. I work the night shifts."

"I see..."

"Anyways, how may I help you?"

In response, Meixiu took out her box of birth control pills and placed it on the counter.

"Can I have another box?" Meixiu asked, feeling a lot less embarrassed compared to her previous visit.

"Sure thing." The clerk smiled and took out another box of birth control pills from under the counter.

"Thank you." Meixiu said.

However, just as she went to pick up the box, the clerk spoke, "By the way, we have a new product that came in just two days ago. Do you want to try it out?"

"What new product?" Meixiu raised an eyebrow.

"This."

The woman then retrieved a small packet that contained four red medicine capsules.

"What's this?" Meixiu asked.

"It's a stimulator of sorts. It will not only give you more energy during your 'sexy time' with your partner, it will even stimulate your senses, allowing you to feel more pleasure. It's quite new, but it's already gained a lot of popularity regardless of the age. Oh, it can be used for either gender."

"Even if you don't need it, I recommend you try it at least once. It will greatly enhance your sex life— speaking from personal experience." The clerk winked at Meixiu in a suggestive manner.

Meixiu swallowed nervously.

"I-I guess I can give it a try..."

After bagging both items, Meixiu quickly returned to her room.

The following day, everybody gathered in the training area once again.

"You will all be fighting this demon today, and since it's stronger than the previous one, you'll return to your original groups— the one with 4-5 people." Yuan said to them.

He turned to face Li Jinxi and asked her, "How do you feel?"

"Never been better," she said.

"Good."

"I'll give you all ten minutes to prepare yourselves. Then I will unseal the demon."

"Yuan." Li Jinxi suddenly approached him.

"Yes?"

"I have a request. Can I fight the demon by myself?"

"Hmm..." Yuan began pondering.

"In your current state, you'll be able to use the nameless technique for at most 10 minutes before you lose control. Your demon sealing aura isn't strong enough to seal it within that time even if it allows you to attack it nonstop. You can try fighting it without the nameless technique, but you won't be its match. In other words, you won't defeat it."

"I know that I won't be able to seal it, but I still want to fight it by myself. It's for experience."

After pondering for a moment, Yuan nodded, "Alright. You can fight it by yourself."

He then turned to look at Wang Ming and said, "You'll replace Li Jinxi and transfer to group one."

"Huh? Why am I replacing her?" Wang Ming asked.

"She wants to fight the demon by herself."

"What?! Are you crazy? You could barely hold your utensils at dinner yesterday!"

"That was yesterday. I am fine now." Li Jinxi said.

"Fuck, she's really inhuman... She must have been adopted into the Li Family, and her real parents are gorillas..." Xi Murong mumbled in a low voice.

"I heard that." Li Jinxi snapped to glare at him.

"Huh? I didn't say anything..." Xi Murong immediately turned around and began whistling.

Chapter 900 - Drastic Improvements

Sometime later, the first group entered the Demon Sealing Zone and waited for Yuan to unseal the demon.

Once it was unsealed, the demon looked around in a calm manner. However, that calmness quickly went away when it saw Chu Liuxiang and the others surrounding it.

"What is the meaning of this?" The demon spoke in a grim voice.

"They are demon sealers, and they will be sealing you, demon." Yuan said.

And he continued, "You are currently within the Demon Sealing Zone, so don't even think about escaping. Of course, you could kill yourself with Core Detonation."

"However, if you accept my request, I will set you free."

The demon narrowed its eyes on Yuan, who was wearing a mask. It then turned to look at the others there.

"What is your request?"

"It's quite simple, really. I want you to fight these demon sealers for the next 7 days. If you can do that, I will set you free."

"What if I kill them?"

"You can try, but it won't happen."

"If I can kill them, will you let me free early?"

"Sure." Yuan calmly nodded.

"Perfect." A malicious grin appeared on the demon's face.

The demon sealers and the demon clashed with each other shortly after.

The demon sealers expected to quickly overpower the demon, but they soon realized that would not be the case, and the demon was able to defend itself and counter attack at the same time.

Compared to the last demon, it was at least twice as hard, and it would take them thrice as long to seal the demon.

Of course, none of them would end up unscathed. Most of them left the Demon Sealing Zone with bruises. In fact, all of them had experienced near-death situations more than once during their fight.

"Holy shit... How can three levels make such a huge difference? We could barely keep up with the demon this time..." Wang Ming exclaimed as he laid on the floor, his body soaked in sweat.

"I don't think we'll be able to fight the demon more than once a day," Chu Liuxiang said while gasping for air.

"How long did it take to seal the demon? It felt like an eternity," Xi Murong asked.

"Two hours and eleven minutes." Wang Bingbing said.

"Two hours?! It only took us 30 minutes to seal the last one!" Hong Xiuquan exclaimed.

Shortly after the first group finished, the second group entered the Demon Sealing Zone and started fighting the demon.

In the end, it took them a little under two hours to seal the demon.

"One hour and fifty one minutes." Wang Ming said to them.

"I knew it wasn't going to be easy, but to think it was that much harder..." Wang Bingbing sighed.

Yuan approached the exhausted demon sealers and said to them, "At this rate, you won't be able to seal the next demon. Therefore, I will be teaching all of you new demon sealing techniques."

"Oh? How many?" Wang Ming asked out of curiosity.

"I have three demon sealing techniques for each of you."

"Three?!"

Yuan nodded, "It might take some time before you're able to use them, but that's not the real purpose. I want you all to increase your demon sealing aura. It's taking all of you too long to seal the demon, and you're in a group. At this rate, it'll take you an entire day to seal the demon by yourself."

"Anyways, line up. I will give you these techniques now."

Thus, everybody there began lining up in front of him.

Sometime later, Yuan transferred three demon sealing techniques to each of them.

"Everyone here besides Jinxi can leave for today. You can also take tomorrow off to study these new techniques. Since I transferred the techniques directly into your mind, you'll be able to comprehend it faster than normal."

Once everyone but Li Jinxi left, Yuan said to her, "Whenever you're ready."

Li Jinxi nodded and entered the Demon Sealing Zone.

The moment Yuan released the demon, Li Jinxi activated her nameless technique.

"Just one of you this time?" The demon grinned when it saw Li Jinxi.

However, despite only facing Li Jinxi, the demon did not underestimate her. In fact, he knew at a glance that she was the strongest out of everyone it's faced today.

The two of them began exchanging blows shortly after.

Li Jinxi easily overpowered the demon in terms of raw strength and speed, but that did not last long.

After 10 minutes of dominance, Li Jinxi could no longer control the nameless technique and began experiencing a backlash.

However, despite feeling like her muscles were being torn apart, Li Jinxi continued to fight the demon for a couple more minutes until she could no longer lift even a single finger.

"You're mine!" The demon laughed as it lunged forward at the unconscious Li Jinxi.

"Maybe next time." Yuan suddenly appeared behind the demon with the Empyrean Overlord in his grasp.

'What?!' The demon didn't notice Yuan's presence until it was too late.

Its body immediately began turning into stone.

'All it took was a single strike?' The demon stared at Yuan in disbelief as it completely turned into stone.

After sealing the demon, Yuan carried Li Jinxi into her room and began massaging her body.

Two days later, the training resumed.

This time, it took the first group only an hour to seal the demon while the second group took around 50 minutes. It was a drastic improvement that nobody there but Yuan had expected.

This continued until the seventh day, where it would take both groups only 15 minutes to seal the demon.

As for Li Jinxi, she was able to use the nameless technique for 20 minutes straight.

"Great job, everyone. It appears that you're all ready for the next demon." Yuan said to them after their training.

"What are you going to do with the demon now?" Wang Ming asked him.

"I'm going to 'free' it, of course." Yuan responded with a calm smile on his face, causing everyone to swallow nervously.

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Chapter 901 - Why Are You Wearing a Mask?

Yuan entered the Demon Sealing Zone and unsealed the demon shortly after Li Jinxi finished her turn.

"I have fulfilled your request, human. You'll set me free as promised." The demon stared at Yuan with a solemn expression.

"Yes, don't worry, I will set you free."

Yuan said as he approached the demon.

"What are you planning?" The demon frowned upon sensing that something was wrong.

However, before it could even react, Yuan extended his hand and grabbed the crystal embedded on its body.

"W-What is the meaning of this, human?!" The demon roared at Yuan.

"What else? I am setting you free."

"Fucking bullshit! You lied to me, human!"

"I didn't lie. You just misunderstood the meaning behind my words, that's all."

"FUCK YOU, YOU DAMN LIVESTOCK!"

The demon became enraged and rushed at Yuan.

"You'll be truly free now." Yuan mumbled in a low voice as he crushed the demon's crystal, instantly killing the demon.

The others were left speechless by Yuan's actions.

"H-He killed the demon just like that?" Wang Ming muttered in disbelief.

"Y-Yuan! Why didn't the demon die when we struck its crystal? I know I'd destroyed it a few times during our training!" Shi Lang asked him.

"That's because it requires a certain technique and a certain level of demon sealing aura to achieve this feat. When you all become strong enough, I will teach you this technique." Yuan said to them.

"It's a promise!"

"Of course."

"Anyways, the next demon won't be unsealed for another week, but I can unseal it early. Take the next five days off. I will deal with the other demons in the meantime."

"Alright."

Yuan approached the Manager afterward and said, "Can you bring all of the demons here tomorrow?"

"A-All of them?" The Manager stared at him with wide eyes.

"Yes. We could wait for them to break out of their seal one by one, or I can kill them all at once."

"Why the sudden rush?" She asked.

"I just remembered that my sister's birthday is coming up soon, so I want to clean things up before I go," he calmly said.

"Is that so..."

"Alright, I will speak with the Lord." The Manager nodded.

"What's wrong? Is there something on my face?" Yuan asked when she continued to stare at him.

"I've been meaning to ask you this but... why are you wearing a mask?"

"Oh, this? The demons would lose all desire to fight if they see my face, and I don't want that." Yuan explained without really going into the details.

"Why would they lose desire to fight if they see your face? That doesn't make any sense..." The Manager asked out of curiosity.

"I don't know. I guess they really hate my face or something." Yuan casually shrugged.

'So he doesn't want to tell me, huh...'

"Whatever." The Manager left shortly after, returning to the peak of the mountain to notify the Lord of the situation.

"He wants to deal with all of the demons at once? I don't have any problems with that. In fact, that's exactly what I want."

The Manager then asked, "Once he defeats all of the demons... are you really going to tell him the truth?"

"He probably already knows the truth. Do you remember what he said? That we came from the Nine Heavens?"

"Of course."

"Then he's already aware of the fact that the Nine Heavens truly exist somewhere in this universe, which is already a third of what we're going to tell him. We might as well tell him everything at this point."

"I guess so..." The Manager sighed.

The following morning, the Manager arrived at Yuan's household with a truck meant for moving furniture.

After parking in the training area, she proceeded to bring out the remaining 9 demons, placing them in an orderly fashion and in the order they would break out of their seal.

"Can you put this one to the side for now? It's going to be the others' practice tool." Yuan pointed at a certain sealed demon and asked the Manager.

"Alright. What about the other demons? Which do you want to kill first?"

"I will handle them all at once. It's more convenient that way, after all."

The Manager frowned and said, "I know you're strong and all, but you shouldn't be so arrogant. You should take the situation more seriously and be more cautious and deal with them one by one."

Yuan sighed, "Fine. I will kill two of them at once, and then I will deal with the strongest one by itself at the end."

"Did you even hear me just now? One. At. A. Time."

"You're underestimating me now, Liya." Yuan smiled.

"How about this? If you let me fight two of them at once, I will fight them without a mask."

"Deal." The Manager immediately agreed, leaving Yuan speechless.

"Was this her intention from the beginning?" He wondered inwardly.

While the Manager moved two of the nine demons into Yuan's Demon Sealing Zone, the others gathered around the area with transportable chairs, acting as though they were going to an outdoor movie.

"Okay, I am ready." The Manager said to Yuan after she finished moving the demons.

"Thank you."

Yuan said as she entered the Demon Sealing Zone.

"Hmm? He's not wearing his mask today?" Wang Bingbing noticed this and asked the others.

"Why does he even feel the need to wear a mask?" Wang Ming asked.

"Do you know?" Xi Murong turned to ask Chu Liuxiang.

"I don't. What about you, Meixiu?" Chu Liuxiang asked her next.

"I don't." She shook her head.

"Even you don't know?" The others were surprised. Out of everyone there, they expected Meixiu to know.

While the others mumbled to each other, Yuan unsealed the demons.

"HAHAHAHA! I AM FREE! FREEEEEE!"

The two demons in the Demon Sealing Zone immediately started laughing out loud.

Yuan patiently waited for the demons to notice him.

When the demons eventually noticed Yuan, they stopped laughing and stared at him with their eyes as wide as saucers.

Chapter 902 - Terrified Demons

"H-Hey... T-That human... Doesn't he look a lot like..."

"Yes... He looks like the D—"

Before the two demons could even fully comprehend the situation, Yuan used his movement technique to instantly close their distance.

"Wha—?!"

"Too late."

The demons tried to distance themselves from Yuan, but it was too late, as he'd grabbed their demon crystals before they could even move.

"Wai—"

And before the demons could even utter a full word, Yuan crushed the crystals, instantly killing them. In fact, not even ten seconds have passed since the demons were released from their seals.

'Fear...? Impossible!' The Manager stared at Yuan with her eyes wide with shock and puzzlement.

'Why would they fear Yuan? No... Can demons even feel fear? It also seemed like the demons recognized him... No... Those demons have been sealed for countless years. There's no way that they could've recognized him. That wouldn't make any logical sense.' The Manager pondered a logical explanation to the phenomenon that had just happened.

"Liya!" Yuan suddenly called for her, bringing her back to reality.

"Can you bring in the next two demons?"

"Che..."

The Manager sucked her teeth before carrying two more demons into the Demon Sealing Zone.

'Why do I have to carry them, anyway?' She wondered inwardly as she placed the last demon into the zone.

"Thanks."

Yuan unsealed the demons shortly after.

The demons instantly noticed Yuan's presence this time around, and when they saw his face, just like the previous two demons, their eyes widened with shock and terror.

'This is definitely the scent of fear! They're fearing him! Why?! Demons have never feared humans before!' The Manager was feeling agitated at this point.

Then she recalled something the Lord had once told her.

'No... There was one entity that demons feared... The Bane of Demons, also known as the Divine Paragon, who freed the Nine Heavens from the Demon Clan's domination.'

However, she couldn't connect the dot between the Divine Paragon and Yuan. After all, these two individuals lived in two different worlds and eras. There was simply no connection between them.

Of course, since she has never seen the Divine Paragon's face before, there was no way that she would have realized the truth.

While the Manager was absorbed in her thoughts, Yuan killed the two demons.

In the blink of an eye, Yuan had killed half of the 8 demons.

"You called me inhuman, right? If I am inhuman, what do you call someone like him?" Li Jinxi asked Xi Murong, who was too shocked to even speak.

However, inside his mind, he could only think of a single word that could describe Yuan.

'God.'

Sometime later, the Manager carried two more demons into the Demon Sealing Zone.

"Y-You are—!"

"I-Impossible! You can't be—"

Once again, Yuan killed the demons before they could even finish a full sentence. Of course, it was made easier due to the demons' fear and confusion.

'He's definitely doing this on purpose! What is he trying to hide?!' The Manager could feel her entire body heating up from anger.

"Manager, the next one." Yuan waved at her with a smile on his face, which only further irritated her.

Sometime later, Yuan unsealed and killed the 7th demon, leaving only one demon— not including the demon that will become a practice tool.

After the Manager carried the final demon into the Demon Sealing Zone, Yuan said to her, "I told you it would be more convenient to just kill them all at once."

"What are you trying to hide from me, Yuan? Why are the demons fearful of you?" She asked him.

"Huh? I have no idea what you're talking about." Yuan shrugged.

'T-This bastard...' The Manager gritted her teeth in frustration, but there was nothing she could do about it, nor could she blame him for wanting to

keep a secret.

After all, she has a secret or two herself.

Yuan unsealed the Spirit Lord demon a few moments later, and to everyone's surprise, he didn't immediately attack it.

The Spirit Lord demon stared at Yuan with wide eyes, but it didn't utter a single word. In fact, it refused to.

'The Divine Paragon?! Why the fuck is he here?!' The demon cried inwardly.

It was so spooked by Yuan's appearance that it didn't even notice his cultivation base.

'Why did he unseal me? Fuck... Is he going to torture me like the rumors?!' The demon trembled in fear when it recalled the countless horror stories about the Divine Paragon with torture being one of the most common story.

'Fuck this shit! I'd rather die than be tortured by the Divine Paragon!'

And without any hesitation, the demon destroyed its own crystal.

"What?! It's killing itself already?!" The others were shocked when the demon suddenly started glowing bright red, almost as though there was a powerful light source illuminating the demon from within.

"I don't think so."

Yuan suddenly summoned the Empyrean Overlord and tossed it at the demon, piercing it right in its chest.

"W-What?!"

The demon exclaimed in a shocked voice when its chaotic energy was sealed quicker than it could expand.

However, since the demon had already destroyed its crystal, it wouldn't be saved just because it was sealed before it could explode.

A few moments after the demon was completely sealed, its body began breaking down itself until it was nothing but a pile of dust.

The entire place was dead silent as everybody there stared at the pile of dust until the wind carried it away, leaving nothing but a demon core behind.

'The strongest demon killed itself...? Why? Because of Yuan's face?' The Manager nearly fell onto her buttocks after witnessing such a ridiculous outcome.

"There's only one demon left now. Make sure you all practice your demon sealing techniques before then." Yuan said to the others.

"O-Okay..." They all nodded in a dazed manner.

Once everyone returned to the household, the Manager approached Yuan and said to him, "Follow me."

"Where are we going?" He asked.

"To speak with the Lord."

Chapter 903 - Unread Messages

"The Lord? Why?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"Now that you have defeated the strongest demon, it will only be a matter of time before the last demon is dealt with. Do you remember your conversation with the Lord? That he'd tell you the truth if you take care of his demon problem?"

"Yeah, I remember." Yuan nodded.

And he continued, "However, there is still one demon left. Until I kill the last demon, I won't speak with him. After all, it was part of the agreement."

"Don't you want to know the truth about Cultivation Online and the Lord's identity?" The Manager frowned at him.

"Of course I do, but I'm in no rush. Why are you so impatient to tell me the truth, though? Did something happen?" He smiled at her.

"N-No... Forget it, then."

The Manager left the place shortly after.

Yuan returned to his room shortly after and practiced the nameless technique.

During dinner, Yuan said, "Meixiu, Lulu, Jinxi, we're going to make our way to the Stairway to Heaven tomorrow."

"Hmm? You're ascending already?" Wang Ming asked.

"No, not yet. I will do it after my sister's birthday, which is in about 2 weeks."

"Your sister?" This was news to some of the people there.

"Yes, my younger sister, Yu Rou. She's currently at another faction. What was the name of their faction again?"

"Eternal Lotuses." Meixiu said.

"Right. Eternal Lotuses."

"Oh, I've heard about them. They're a pretty popular and powerful female-only faction." Wang Bingbing said.

"We should probably notify her before we see her. They forbid men from visiting." Meixiu said.

"Hmm... but I don't want to ruin the surprise..." Yuan sighed.

"I know! Meixiu, can you contact the leader of the Eternal Lotuses? I will talk with the leader directly and receive permission so that it wouldn't ruin the surprise."

"Alright. I will contact the Cultivators' Association and ask them to set up a schedule."

"Thank you."

After dinner, Meixiu returned to her own room and called Chairman Lee, the head of the Cultivators' Association.

After a single ring, Chairman Lee picked up the phone and spoke in an excited voice, "Hello?!"

"Hello, Chairman Lee. This is Meixiu from the Demon Sealing Faction."

"Oh! Lady Meixiu! I have been waiting for your call!" Chairman Lee sounded as though he was on the verge of crying through the phone.

'Lady Meixiu...?' Meixiu raised an eyebrow.

"Lady Meixiu, before you say anything, I must ask, have you checked your email since the creation of the Demon Sealing Faction?" Chairman Lee suddenly asked.

"Email? No, I haven't. Why?"

"You should probably take a look at it... You will understand quicker that way."

"Okay, give me a minute."

Meixiu went to grab her laptop and checked her email.

"This is..." Meixiu was shocked when she saw how many unread messages were in her email.

[Unread Messages: 9,999+]

There were many types of messages.

Messages from people who wanted to join the Demon Sealing Faction, messages from other factions that were hoping to form an alliance with them, and most of all, messages from news organizations that wanted to interview their faction— mostly Yuan.

After the creation of the Demon Sealing Faction, news of Player Yuan being its leader spread like wildfire, and people from all over the world wanted to contact them.

However, the only way to contact them was through Meixiu's email, which she'd neglected until now. Because of this, people started contacting the Cultivators' Association instead, but there was nothing they could do besides sending more messages to Meixiu.

"Sorry... I'd completely forgotten about it." Meixiu apologized to Chairman Lee after realizing her mistake.

"It's alright. Better late than never." Chairman Lee chuckled.

"Anyways, is there anything the Cultivators' Association can do for you, Lady Meixiu?"

"Yes, I have a request. Yuan would like to speak with the leader of the Eternal Lotuses. Can you contact them and let them know?"

"The leader of Eternal Lotuses? That would be White Lotus. May I ask for a reason? The Eternal Lotuses will want to know your reason, as well."

"Yuan's little sister is a member of the Eternal Lotuses, and it will be her birthday soon. He wants to surprise her with a visit, but the Eternal Lotuses don't allow men to enter, so we were hoping to work something out."

"Yuan's little sister? I understand. I will contact White Lotus after this, but she might not respond for a while. They're a powerful faction with a popular leader, so they're bound to be very busy."

"I understand. Thank you."

"No need to be humble, Lady Meixiu. The Cultivators' Association is here for you." Chairman Lee said.

Of course, only powerful factions like the Demon Sealing Faction could receive such privileges.

After hanging up, Meixiu placed her phone beside the bed and started going through some unread messages out of curiosity.

Meanwhile, Chairman Lee called the Eternal Lotuses' headquarters.

"Hello, this is Chairman Lee of the Cultivators' Association. I have some important matters to discuss with White Lotus."

"Miss Bai is currently cultivating. Can this wait until tomorrow?" White Lotus' Manager answered the phone.

"I don't mind waiting. Tell White Lotus that Player Yuan from the Demon Sealing Faction would like to speak with her. Call me back when you're ready to speak. That's all."

"W-Wait! Did you just say Player—"

However, Chairman Lee closed the connection before the Manager could even finish her sentence. Of course, this was on purpose, as it would give them more pressure and a sense of urgency.

After staring at her phone in a dazed manner for many moments, the Manager went to look for White Lotus.

"Miss Bai! I apologize for bothering you during your cultivation, but this is urgent!" The Manager knocked on her door.

A few moments later, a white-haired beauty opened the door and appeared before the Manager.

"What is it?"

"Chairman Lee from the Cultivators' Association just called, and he said that Player Yuan from the Demon Sealing Faction would like to speak with you!"

White Lotus immediately narrowed her eyes upon hearing this information.

'Player Yuan? Why would he want to speak with me?' She curiously wondered.

Chapter 904 - Silver Spirit Grass

White Lotus was surprised and confused at the same time when she received news that Player Yuan had reached out to her.

According to her knowledge, Yuan has never reached out to any other player, and this only further increased her curiosity.

What could Player Yuan possibly want from her when he seemingly already has everything?

"Call Chairman Lee back and tell him to let Player Yuan know that I am willing to speak with him. However, I'd like to do it in Cultivation Online if that's possible."

"Y-You want to speak with Player Yuan in Cultivation Online?" Her manager looked at her with wide eyes.

"Aren't you curious? The infamous Player Yuan who's been dominating Cultivation Online since day one. His achievements are light years ahead of everyone else, and he acquired most of them within the first month. However, he's been awfully quiet since his last announcement when he opened the Stairway to Heaven to the second world, almost as though he'd disappeared from this world."

"Okay, I will call Chairman Lee now."

A few moments later, Chairman Lee picked up his phone, "This is Chairman Lee."

"Good evening, Chairman Lee. This is Bai Lianhua. Is it true that Player Yuan wants to speak with me?" White Lotus asked.

"Yes, that is true. I'm sure you're curious as to why. Let me tell—"

"No, don't tell me. I want to ask him for myself." White Lotus interrupted.

"If that's what you wish. When are you available? I will help the two of you schedule an online chat room, where the two of you can chat with each other."

"That's not necessary. I wish to speak with Player Yuan in Cultivation Online in person. Tell him that I will be at the Wuyue Pavilion in Wuyue City in three hours. It's very close to the starting city in the second world. If he's not able to make it there in time, I can wait for him."

"Okay, I will let them know of your response. I will call you back when I get their response."

Chairman Lee hung up the phone and called Meixiu.

"This is Chairman Lee. I have just contacted White Lotus of the Eternal Lotuses. She agrees to meet with Player Yuan, but she wishes to meet him in Cultivation Online in three hours. The location is at Wuyue Pavilion in Wuyue City by the starting city in the second world. Is he able to make it?"

"Give me a minute. I will go ask him right now." Meixiu placed the phone down and went to knock on Yuan's door.

Once Yuan opened the door, Meixiu relayed the news to him.

"I see. Wuyue Pavilion in Wuyue City, right? Let them know that I will be there." Yuan nodded.

While Yuan logged into Cultivation Online, Meixiu told Chairman Lee of the situation.

"Thank you, I will let White Lotus know immediately."

"No, thank you for the help." Meixiu said before hanging up.

After logging into Cultivation Online, Yuan immediately began making his way towards Wuyue City.

Since the destination was quite close to the starting city in Spirit Heaven, it didn't take even an hour for Yuan to arrive.

After arriving at the city, Yuan decided to take a tour around the city since he had plenty of time left before the meeting.

'Since I am going to be asking White Lotus for a favor, I should probably give her a gift, right? First impressions are quite important, after all.'

With that in mind, Yuan began pondering what he should gift White Lotus.

Then he recalled something Yu Rou had told him before.

'White Lotus was the first player to have a servant. I should probably give her something that would benefit her servant.'

Yuan immediately began looking for a store that would have such gifts.

However, it was quite late at night, so most of the stores were closed.

Then he recalled something else.

"Feng Feng, do you happen to have more Spirit Fruits on you?" Yuan asked her.

"Spirit Fruits? No, I gave what I had left to you when we first met," she said.

"If you don't mind me asking, why do you need Spirit Fruits?"

"I am meeting someone later, and I want to give her a gift. She's probably a beast tamer, so I want to give her something related to that," Yuan explained.

"I see... Do you know what kind of magical beast she's tamed?"

"No, I don't."

"Hmm..."

Feng Yuxiang pondered for a moment before speaking again, "I have a suggestion, Young Master. Since you don't know what kind of magical beast she's tamed, you can just give her something that will benefit most magical beasts. I have something called 'Silver Spirit Grass'. Not only is it the favorite food for many magical beasts, it can even boost their cultivation growth rate by 50 percent until they reach Spirit Master."

"That sounds perfect. How much do they usually cost? I'll pay you for some." Yuan said.

"I-It's alright, Young Master. It doesn't cost too much, so you can just have them for free."

Yuan raised an eyebrow and asked her, "Are you saying that because it's really that cheap, or are you saying that because it's too expensive for me? Knowing you, I doubt you would have anything cheap on you. Tell me the truth, Feng Feng."

"It cost 5,000,000 spirit stones for a batch of Silver Spirit Grass..."

"5,000,000..." Yuan swallowed nervously.

He rubbed his eyes for a moment before speaking, "Don't worry, I can afford it after selling the Gu Family's treasures. I will pay you back later."

"You really don't have to..."

"No, I must. Otherwise, it wouldn't feel like a gift since I got it from someone else for free."

"If you insist, Young Master."

Sometime later, Yuan made his way to the Wuyue Pavilion even though there was still an hour left. It was an open area surrounded by an artificial

pond. It was also a lively outdoor restaurant that had dancers in the middle and musicians on each side.

Yuan swept the entire area with his divine sense until he noticed a beautiful white-haired young woman who was sitting by herself at a small round table, yet she was surrounded by young men that were trying to get her attention.

Seeing this, Yuan shook his head inwardly and approached the table with the white-haired beauty.

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Chapter 905 - Meeting White Lotus

Chapter 905 - Meeting White Lotus

"Hey, pretty. Why are you sitting here by yourself? Why don't you come sit with us. It'll be our treat."

"Come sit with my friends, young fairy. We just got accepted into the Seven Spirit Academies, so we're celebrating."

"It's a crime for a beauty such as yourself to be alone, come with me. I'll spend the whole night with you."

The white-haired beauty sighed, "I'm waiting for my friend, so you'll have to entertain yourselves without me."

However, the young men did not leave and became even more motivated.

'Why must the men be even more annoying in this world...' The white-haired beauty sighed inwardly.

"Excuse me, I'd like to get through." A calm voice suddenly resounded amongst the dozens of voices there.

"Huh? Who the hell are you? Can't you see that there's a line here?"

"I know you're horny, but wait for your turn, buddy."

It was at this moment a powerful pressure suddenly enveloped the place, startling everybody there.

Although the pressure was only directly at certain people there and lasted only a second, it was strong enough to completely silence the entire place.

The white-haired beauty then watched as the people around her moved to the side with terrified expressions on their faces, creating a path for someone.

"Hello, you must be White Lotus." Yuan greeted the white-haired beauty when he approached the table.

White Lotus looked at Yuan with her eyes slightly widened, and she subconsciously swallowed nervously.

"Are you Player Yuan?" She asked after a moment of silence.

"You can just call me Yuan." He nodded.

"Can I sit here?" He then pointed at the chair on the opposite side of her.

"Please."

Once he was seated, the people around them started to disappear, and the music resumed. However, the overall noise in that place remained quite low, almost as though the people there were afraid of disturbing someone.

"I hope you didn't wait too long for me." Yuan said to her.

"It's fine, I wasn't expecting for you to show up this early, either," she said.

And she continued, "I was surprised when Chairman Lee called me. I never expected to be contacted by the famous Player Yuan who has remained a mystery since the start of Cultivation Online."

"A mystery, huh? I just never had a reason to speak with other Players, I guess." Yuan said.

"Nevertheless, I'm glad that you'd reached out to me. I have always wanted to meet you." White Lotus said with a slight smile on her face.

"You wanted to meet me? Why?" Yuan raised an eyebrow.

"I was very proud to become the first player to have a servant, yet you'd made my achievement completely obsolete with your Divine-grade servant. Do you have any idea how that made me feel? I have never felt so humiliated before."

"Sorry, that wasn't my intention."

"I know, and I am not blaming you." White Lotus shook her head.

"Anyways, why did you want to speak with me?"

Yuan raised his eyebrows in a puzzled manner.

"Chairman Lee didn't tell you?" He asked.

"It's not that he didn't tell me. I just figured that it would be better if I heard it directly from you rather than through another person. That would be more sincere, after all."

"I see..."

"Then before I tell you, allow me to give you this."

Yuan retrieved the Silver Spirit Grass and placed it on the table.

White Lotus looked at the bundle of grass with a confused face.

"Why is he giving me grass?" She wondered to herself.

"Since you're the first Player to have acquired a servant, I figured this would be a perfect gift for you. It's called Silver Spirit Grass. If you feed it to your servant, it will boost their cultivation speed by 50 percent until they reach the strength of a Spirit Master."

"What?!" White Lotus exclaimed in a shocked voice.

"I know it's not much since I didn't have enough time to prepare—"

"I-I cannot accept such a gift. It's too valuable." White Lotus suddenly interrupted.

And she continued in a nervous voice, "I saw a treasure with similar effects before, but it was only at 10 percent, and it was already worth a million spirit stones. I cannot imagine how much this treasure with 50 percent effect is worth..."

"Don't worry about it. If you don't use it, I will have to give it to someone else since I have no use for it."

White Lotus stared at the Silver Spirit Grass with a pondering face.

However, before she could even come to a conclusion, a shadowy figure suddenly shot out from her body and started gnawing on the Silver Spirit Grass.

"X-Xu Hei! Stop!" White Lotus shouted in a panicked voice when she realized that it was her servant that was eating the priceless Silver Spirit Grass.

But alas, the Silver Spirit Grass disappeared almost immediately.

"N-No way..." White Lotus could feel all of her strength leave her body as she watched millions of spirit stones disappear into her servant's stomach.

"A cat with two tails? So this is your servant, huh?" Yuan stared at the cat with interest.

"I-I'm so sorry!" White Lotus suddenly stood up and apologized with her head lowered.

Meow

The Two-tailed Black Cat looked at Yuan with a thankful gaze.

"I will accept your apology if you listen to my request." Yuan smiled.

"Anything!" White Lotus quickly said.

"You see, my little sister, Yu Rou, is actually a member of your faction. It is going to be her birthday soon, and I'd like to surprise her with a visit. However, I heard that your faction doesn't allow men to enter, so I wanted to see if I could work something out with you, the leader of the faction."

White Lotus stared at him with a dumbfounded face.

"T-This is the reason he wanted to contact me?!" She cried inwardly.

"Wait... Did you just say Yu Rou? You're her brother?" She asked him after a moment of silence.

"Yes, I am. Do you know her?"

White Lotus nodded in a dazed manner.

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Chapter 906 - Meeting White Lotus

(2)

Chapter 906 - Meeting White Lotus (2)

"Yu Rou is one of the most talented new recruits we had recently, so it's hard to miss her. But to think that she was the little sister of 'Yuan', I am truly speechless." White Lotus said.

"How is she doing in the faction? It's been a while since I spoke with her. Although she's called multiple times, I am always busy, and when I try calling her back, she's busy with practice, so I haven't been able to speak with her recently, not to mention the difference in time zone." Yuan sighed.

"Yu Rou is very diligent in her training. She's always the first one there and the last to leave. Because of her commitment, she's earned all of the instructors' respects. For her to have such discipline, she must have wonderful parents."

"..."

When their parents were mentioned, Yuan's expression suddenly turned cold, and killing intent began leaking from him.

'Eh?' White Lotus was quite startled by such a drastic change in atmosphere, and she began worrying that she might have said something she shouldn't have.

"Excuse me." Yuan noticed the scared look on White Lotus' face and quickly controlled his emotions.

"I'm sorry if I—"

"No, it wasn't your fault. I just remembered some unpleasant memories, that's all."

And he continued, "Anyways, I know that I am asking a lot from you, but if you cannot let me meet with Yu Rou at your place, can you help me meet up with Yu Rou somewhere outside? I want it to remain as a surprise, so if you could, don't let her know that she's going to meet me."

White Lotus pondered Yuan's request as she looked at Xu Hei, who was still sitting on the table and licking its lips.

"Alright, I will make it an exception and allow you to enter our land to celebrate Yu Rou's birthday."

"Really? Thank you!" Yuan immediately smiled.

"This is the least I can do for you. Just let me know when you plan on stopping by." White Lotus smiled back.

"Great!" Yuan proceeded to tell her the date of Yu Rou's birthday.

Sometime later, he asked her, "Since we're already here, why don't we eat something? It'll be my treat."

"Sure." White Lotus nodded.

Once a waiter approached their table, they began ordering their food.

Due to their table's small size, Yuan decided to order a simple dish and some tea.

While they waited for their food, Yuan asked, "I have been wondering about how other Players enjoy their time in Cultivation Online. Can you tell me some of your experiences in this world? In return, I will tell you some of mine."

"Sure." White Lotus accepted without hesitation.

After all, any information about Yuan's experience was incredibly valuable and highly sought after by the entire world.

And for the next twenty minutes, White Lotus recalled some of her adventures with Yuan.

Although they were not as grand and as exciting as Yuan's adventures, it was still interesting in its own way.

Once the food was ready, they took a break from talking to eat and enjoy the music.

Afterward, Yuan shared some of his earlier experiences with White Lotus.

He spoke about how he'd fought a horde of monsters to protect Pang City. He spoke of his experience at the Dragon Essence Temple and how he participated in a zither competition with a fellow disciple. He spoke of the Mystic Realm. He spoke about powerful entities known as demons, and how he'd visited a world of dragons that looked like humans.

White Lotus was absolutely captivated by his wondrous experience— so much so that she'd completely lost track of time.

In fact, she had a thrilled expression on her face the entire time, but she was too absorbed to be aware of her own expression.

White Lotus wanted Yuan to continue his story forever, but the Wuyue Pavilion had a closing time, and it was reached before either of them were aware.

"Excuse me, esteemed guests. Wuyue Pavilion will be closing soon. However, if you wish to stay here and continue chatting, you are free to do so." The manager of the place approached them in a timid manner, as he was afraid to anger them by disturbing their peaceful atmosphere.

"It's already closing time? I'm sorry, Yuan. I didn't intend on taking up so much of your time." White Lotus said to him.

"It was enjoyable, so I don't mind." Yuan smiled.

White Lotus nodded and said, "Let's continue this conversation another time."

"Here is my phone number. If you need anything, don't hesitate to call." She retrieved a piece of paper and started writing on it.

"Thank you." Yuan accepted the paper and memorized the number with a single glance.

"I know you're coming for Yu Rou, but I look forward to your visit as well. Goodnight." White Lotus said to him before logging off.

Yuan logged off shortly after.

After logging off, White Lotus removed the helmet and proceeded to stare at her ceiling with a dazed look on her face.

"Yuan, huh? What an intriguing person. He's nothing like the rumors." A gentle smile appeared on her face.

Then she realized something.

"I completely forgot! I wanted to ask him about his servants! What a blunder!" She facepalmed herself upon realizing this.

"I wanted to see what a Divine-grade and Ancient-grade servant looked like, too! Damn it!"

Sometime later, once she calmed down, White Lotus got off the bed and walked to her computer.

After logging into the computer, she opened up a private chat room and typed into the chat box—

[White Lotus: I just met with Player Yuan in Cultivation Online. We chatted about our experience with the game over some food and tea. He's truly a unique person with many stories to tell.]

Within seconds of White Lotus' comment, dozens of people started typing in the chat.

[Blue Monster: No way! Really?! Where did you meet him?!]

[Green Hat: Tell us what happened!]

[Fiery Queen: How did you contact him?! I also want to speak with him!]

However, White Lotus didn't respond to any of them.

After reading some of the responses, she'd closed the chat room and walked away from her computer with a smug smile on her face.

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Chapter 907 - Teasing the Legacy Families

Chapter 907 - Teasing the Legacy Families

After White Lotus teased everyone in the chat room with the information that she'd met with Player Yuan, hundreds of people began trying to reach out to White Lotus.

They tried messaging her through emails, through the chat room, and even through her phone.

When none of that worked, they started calling her and those around her.

"Miss Bai... They're calling us nonstop. Why don't you just respond to them?" Her manager pleaded with her, as her phone has been blowing up nonstop for the past hour.

"Just turn off your phone like I did." White Lotus smiled.

"And then it will only be a matter of time before they start showing up at our doorstep. In fact, I am willing to bet that some of them are already on their way here!" Her manager sighed.

"Let them come. They're always talking about Player Yuan, so I am teasing them for a bit."

"You're so evil, Miss Bai..."

"It'll only be for a bit." White Lotus shrugged.

The following day, as expected, a crowd of people showed up in front of the Eternal Lotuses' headquarters.

Of course, they were all females. And because they were all from Legacy Families, the Eternal Lotuses couldn't just send them away.

"Miss Bai, here are the families that are currently outside." Her manager handed her a list of names.

"Oh? Fiery Queen is also here?" White Lotus noticed her name at glance.

"Yes, and she said that she won't leave until you meet with her." The manager sighed.

White Lotus smiled and said, "Bring her inside. Tell the others that I am only going to be speaking with Fiery Queen and nobody else."

"Right away."

Sometime later, a beautiful young woman with long, wavy crimson hair appeared before White Lotus in her room.

"White Lotus! How dare you leave us hanging after dropping that bomb in the chat room yesterday! Do you have any idea how much ruckus your comment had caused?!" Fiery Queen began lecturing White Lotus the moment she entered the room.

"Ruckus? It was just a casual comment. Why would there be a ruckus?" White Lotus acted ignorant.

"Y-You met with Player Yuan, right? The mysterious player that shook the entire world with his impossible achievements! Everybody and their mother has been trying to contact him but to no avail. Even a teaspoon of information on him is worth a fortune! You must tell me about your meeting with him!"

"Why should I tell you— or anybody, for that matter? It was a private conversation between the two of us. There's no need for the whole world to know about it." White Lotus shook her head.

"Bullshit! Then why did you mention it in the group chat? You could've kept the meeting to yourself!"

"I just wanted to see your reactions, that's all."

Fiery Queen was speechless.

"You're a really horrible person, you know that, right?"

White Lotus chuckled, "Is that so? I was going to give you a chance to meet him, but since I am a horrible person..."

"W-Wait! I was joking! You're not a horrible person! Please, I want to meet him, too!" Fiery Queen began panicking.

White Lotus then said, "If you're thinking about recruiting him, I suggest you give up on that idea."

"Why? Did you already recruit him or something?" Fiery Queen frowned.

"No, I didn't even try to recruit him."

"Why not?"

"You wouldn't understand it until you meet him. That man... He's untamable." White Lotus sighed.

"You won't know until you try." Fiery Queen said.

"Try?" White Lotus scoffed, and she continued, "When I first met him, I was barely able to keep my composure. I felt like a prey before its predator — it was a truly humbling experience. Even though he was very polite and humble, he has this overwhelming presence that cannot be masked."

"So you're saying that he's a dangerous individual?" Fiery Queen raised her eyebrows.

"Yes and no. He seems like a genuinely good person and someone easy to befriend, but if you offend him, he'll become your worst nightmare. He's

that sort of individual." White Lotus said, recalling her experience with Yuan.

"Unfortunately, even if I trust you, this is not something we can decide on. It'll be our families that will make the final decision. Speaking of our families, has your family contacted you yet?" Fiery Queen asked her.

"No, they haven't."

"Well, color me surprised."

"But it'll only be a matter of time." White Lotus said.

"What will you do if they want you to recruit him?" Fiery Queen asked.

"Then I'll recruit him." She calmly said.

Fiery Queen frowned and said, "Even after everything you'd just said? You're such a hypocrite."

"He's going to refuse, anyways. The most important thing is the way we approach him and that we don't push our luck."

"You knew this was going to happen before you even made that comment in the group chat yesterday. Why?"

"Who knows." White Lotus shrugged.

White Lotus suddenly noticed her private cell phone ringing.

"Speaking of the devil. Looks like my family has finally decided to contact me," she said with a smile.

"If you don't mind..." White Lotus looked at Fiery Queen.

"We're not done yet! I will be waiting outside!" Fiery Queen said before going outside.

White Lotus answered the phone and began speaking with her parents.

"Yes, it's true."

"No, not yet. I didn't want to rush things."

"Don't worry, I will have another chance to meet him soon."

"Yes, I know. I will do my best to recruit him."

"Sorry, but I promised him that I wouldn't reveal any information about our meeting yesterday."

"Even if it's my own family, there is a chance that it could be leaked outside. Unless you want to risk offending him and lose our chance to recruit him..."

"I understand. Goodbye."

White Lotus hung up many minutes later and sighed in relief.

Meanwhile, on the other side of the world, Yuan logged into Cultivation Online and met up with those that will be ascending the Stairway to Heaven with him.

Chapter 908 - Confronting the Gu Family

Chapter 908 - Confronting the Gu Family

"Are you guys ready?" Yuan asked Meixiu and the others after returning to the starting city.

"I'm ready." Chu Liuxiang nodded.

"Same." Meixiu said.

Li Jinxi silently nodded.

"Great. Now then... which way is the Stairway to Heaven?" Yuan asked his companions.

Xiao Hua appeared the next moment and pointed in a certain direction.

"Since I don't want to take up too much of your time, let's fly there." Yuan said afterward.

"Fly?" Li Jinxi raised her eyebrows.

Yuan then used Qi Manifestation to wrap his spiritual energy around them before lifting them into the air.

Although Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang were used to the feeling of flight, this was Li Jinxi's first time flying in such a manner.

"Brother Yuan, do you need help?" Xiao Hua asked him.

"It's fine. I have plenty of spiritual energy." He said.

Thus, they began flying towards the Stairway to Heaven, unaware of the army waiting for them.

Meanwhile, somewhere near the Stairway to Heaven.

"Patriarch Gu, there is still no sign of this 'Yuan'. Do you think the information provided to us could be fake? It's already been a week since we've started camping out here." An elder of the Gu Family said.

"No, that's not possible. The person who provided me this information is a reputable source. He wouldn't lie to me." Patriarch Gu said.

And he continued, "We'll wait here for a whole month if we have to. Stay vigilant. You never know when he'll show up."

"Yes."

Meanwhile, inside the House of Riches, Gu Xiulan was lying on the couch staring at the Spirit Jade Feng Yuxiang gave to her when someone knocked on her door.

"What is it?" Gu Xiulan stored the Spirit Jade away and turned to look at the door.

"Manager, have you heard? Patriarch Gu left the Gu Family with over a thousand experts and stationed themselves around the Stairway to Heaven."

"What? When did this happen?" Gu Xiulan frowned.

"About a week ago."

"Do you know why?"

"No, I don't."

After pondering for a moment, two figures suddenly appeared inside her head.

'Oh no! Don't tell me it's because of them!' Gu Xiulan immediately sat up on the bed and retrieved a communication jade slip.

"Damn it! He's not picking up! What's that idiot doing?!"

Gu Xiulan rushed outside and said, "I will be away for a bit!"

After leaving the House of Riches, Gu Xiulan began flying towards the direction of the Stairway to Heaven.

'I really hope I won't be too late to stop their foolishness!' She prayed as she flew.

"Hmm? Why are there so many people here?" Yuan wondered out loud as they approached the Stairway to Heaven and noticed the people at the bottom.

"Halt!"

A loud voice suddenly resounded, and a figure with the strength of a Spirit Grandmaster approached them a moment later.

"State your name!" The Spirit Grandmaster demanded.

"Huh? Why do I have to give you my name?" Yuan raised an eyebrow.

"Insolence! You're standing before the Gu Family, one of Seven Legacy Families! I will not repeat myself! Identify yourselves!" The Spirit Grandmaster repeated.

'Gu Family, huh? Why are they out here? Are they waiting for us— for me?' Yuan wondered inwardly.

"My name is Tian Chenyu." Yuan calmly responded.

He turned to look at the others and nodded his head.

"Chu Liuxiang."

"Meixiu."

"Li Jinxi."

"Xiao Hua."

The ladies all introduced themselves.

The Spirit Grandmaster looked at the list in his hand. When he couldn't see any of their names on it, he nodded and said, "You may pass."

"Thank you." Yuan didn't say anything else and began flying away.

However, he suddenly turned around and extended his hand, catching a sword that had been flying at him.

Yuan glanced at the sword in his grasp before looking at the Spirit Grandmaster.

"What's the meaning of this?" He asked.

"Do you really take me for a fool, Yuan?" The Spirit Grandmaster sneered.

"How dare you attack Brother Yuan's back..." Xiao Hua's eyes flickered with killing intent.

"Wait, Xiao Hua." Yuan beckoned her to stop.

"How did you know?" He then asked the Spirit Grandmaster.

The Spirit Grandmaster then retrieved a jade slip and activated it, which immediately projected Yuan's face.

"That looks like the disciple examination... Someone had captured my appearance through the broadcast, huh?" Yuan quickly realized how the Spirit Grandmaster knew his true identity.

The Spirit Grandmaster then retrieved a talisman and activated it.

The talisman suddenly exploded with light, just like a firework.

When the rest of the Gu Family noticed the firework, they immediately started approaching their location, and within moments, hundreds of experts surrounded Yuan and his group.

"I was worried that you wouldn't come, bandit who dared to rob my Gu Family." Patriarch Gu showed up shortly afterward.

"Yuan... What's going on here?" Li Jinxi asked him.

"Don't worry, I will handle it. Feng Feng, Xiao Hua, Yingying, I will leave them in your hands."

Feng Yuxiang and Lan Yingying appeared the next moment and formed a triangle around Meixiu and the others with Xiao Hua.

"Where the hell did they come from?"

"Wow, I have never seen so many jade beauties in one place before..."

The Gu Family was shocked by Feng Yuxiang and Lan Yingying's sudden appearance.

"You called a whole army just to punish me? I'm flattered." Yuan said to Patriarch Gu.

"I admire your ability to stay calm in such a situation, so I am going to give you a way out. Hand over the treasures that you had stolen from my family and I will let you leave with your life. However, you will no longer be a cultivator."

"..."

Yuan glanced at Meixiu and the others.

Although Tian Chenyu has killed other cultivators before, they were all demon worshippers that have colluded with demons, so it doesn't make it

any easier for Yuan to kill these people even with Tian Chenyu's memories and experience.

Furthermore, he didn't want Meixiu and the others to see him slaughtering other people.

"I don't know what you're talking about. I never stole anything from your family. What had happened was—"

"I don't care about your side of the story. You have something that belongs to my family and that's all it matters." Patriarch Gu interrupted.

"If you insist on opposing my Gu Family, then you leave me no other choice. Since you stole something from me, it is only fair that I take something from you."

Patriarch Gu pointed at the ladies behind him and spoke in a cold voice, "After I kill you, I will take back my treasures along with your women and make them my Gu Family's slaves for the rest of their lives, and everyone here will have a chance to enjoy them!"

When Patriarch Gu's people heard his words, they immediately began shouting in excitement.

"Is that so..." Yuan lowered his head and muttered in a low voice.

A cold voice suddenly resounded in his head the next moment.

'Regardless if they are Immortal or God, slaughter all that obstruct your path! Let your bloodlust consume the heavens and all those within it! Kill these ants that dares to covet your women! Let them know true fear!'

When Yuan heard the Evil God's voice, his eyes suddenly turned blood red, and his body began oozing with killing intent so intense that it was possible to see with one's bare eyes.

"Y-Young Master..."

Feng Yuxiang swallowed nervously when she noticed red mist filled with killing intent being discharged from Yuan's body, resembling the miasma at the Demons' Valley, and it gave her a sensation of dread and despair that not even demons could achieve.

"Brother Yuan..." Xiao Hua's body trembled in fear when she sensed Yuan's killing intent. This is the second time that she's seen him in such a state. The first time she saw it she was reminded of her father, and it was even more so this time, almost as though her father was standing in Yuan's place right now.

"W-Watch out! There's something off about him!" Patriarch Gu immediately warned the others, and this was before Yuan's killing intent reached him.

Once he felt Yuan's killing intent, it made his blood turn cold, and it felt like his body had turned into an ice statue.

When the others with a lower cultivation sensed Yuan's killing intent, they started screaming with madness, almost as though they'd lost their mind or they were actively being tortured.

The entire area quickly became filled with shrieks and people screaming, almost as though they'd suddenly entered the deepest parts of hell.

Chapter 909 - Evil God's Killing Intent

Chapter 909 - Evil God's Killing Intent

"Aaaahh!!!"

"Somebody! Kill me! End this pain!"

"Help me! Mommy!"

Hundreds of cultivators screamed like their lives depended on it, almost as though they were being tortured.

It didn't matter if they were Spirit Grandmasters or stone-cold killers—none of them were spared.

The only ones that could barely maintain their sanity were those at Spirit Lord and above.

"W-What is going on?" Li Jinxi looked at the chaos around them with a terrified face.

"Have they gone mad? Did Yuan do this to them?" Chu Liuxiang swallowed nervously.

Of course, the only ones that weren't affected by the Evil God's killing intent were Meixiu and the others.

"This killing intent reminds me of our training at the Qi Family but countless times stronger..." Meixiu mumbled in a dazed voice as she stared at Yuan's figure from behind.

'What happened to you, Yuan?' Meixiu sighed inwardly, feeling worried about Yuan's condition.

Eventually, the red mist released by Yuan covered a distance of 10 miles, and all greenery within his miasma would die, turning the scenery into that of something similar to an apocalypse.

The magical beasts and animals all ran for their lives, and those that weren't fast enough to escape the miasma would fall unconscious with their longevity slowly being consumed by their intense fear.

The cultivators with the Gu Family eventually started harming themselves and those around them.

They scratched their faces until it was covered in blood. Some of them even dug out their own eyeballs.

The scene was becoming more and more gruesome with every passing second.

After snapping out of her daze, Feng Yuxiang created a wall of flame around Meixiu and the others so they wouldn't be able to see the scene any longer.

Patriarch Gu also snapped out of his daze and shouted, "Everyone! Stop him! We cannot allow this to go on any further!"

All of the Spirit Lords that were still sane immediately began throwing everything they had at Yuan.

Although they were all scared to death and wanted to turn around and run, nobody there dared to turn their backs to Yuan.

"Disappear from my sight." Yuan muttered in a cold voice when he noticed their movements.

There were a total of 13 Spirit Lords in the Gu Family, so Yuan created 12 clones of the Starry Abyss and attacked them with Flying Dagger.

Despite their small size, the Starry Abyss pierced through the air with tremendous force that could easily crush even a peak Spirit Lord.

Like 13 shooting stars, the Starry Abyss soared through the sky until they reached their targets.

"Ah!"

More screams resounded as 10 out of 13 Spirit Lords perished from Yuan's Mortal-rank technique.

As for the remaining three Spirit Lords, they were barely able to escape with their lives, but none of them managed to escape unharmed, and two of them were even crippled in the process.

"Impossible... How can a single person possess such power? He's only a Spirit Lord, too!" Patriarch Gu exclaimed.

'It's over... I have offended a monster that we couldn't afford to offend... And for what...? For those idiots in the Lower Heaven?'

Patriarch Gu lost all desire to retaliate and just hovered in the air with a blank look on his face. He'd completely given up.

"Young Master, please have mercy!" A voice suddenly resounded.

Patriarch Gu subconsciously turned to the sound.

"Gu Xiulan...? What are you doing here?" He asked her.

However, Gu Xiulan ignored Patriarch Gu and flew past him until she was in front of Yuan.

She immediately kowtowed in the air and begged, "Please! Have mercy! This is all caused by a misunderstanding!"

"A misunderstanding, you say?" Yuan narrowed his eyes at her.

"Yes! Our Gu Family is at fault here! We will bear all responsibility for what happened here today!" She said.

Yuan suddenly felt someone tugging his clothes from behind.

He turned around to see Xiao Hua. She had her head lowered, almost as though she was too afraid to look at him, and her petite body was shivering uncontrollably.

"B-Brother Yuan... Xiao Hua is afraid..." She mumbled in a low voice.

Yuan's eyes widened, and he immediately stopped releasing the Evil God's killing intent. However, the red miasma continued to linger for a while before slowly disappearing.

He placed his hand on her head and sighed, "I'm sorry, Xiao Hua. I lost control of my emotions just now and scared you."

Xiao Hua lifted her head to see a gentle smile on his face.

She wiped the tears around her eyes and smiled, "It's okay."

Yuan nodded, and he proceeded to look at the chaos he's caused with his killing intent alone.

Even though the miasma was quickly clearing, the cultivators from the Gu Family weren't calming down, and they continued to harm each other.

Yuan turned to look at Gu Xiulan and Patriarch Gu. Their faces were pale white, and Patriarch Gu looked especially bad, almost as though he'd painted his face with white paint.

"I won't apologize for what happened here today. If you'd given me a chance to explain myself without threatening harm to my friends, things wouldn't have gotten this bad."

"I-I deeply apologize for my behavior and rashness. Please, spare my Gu Family. I was the one who spoke about harming your friends. Take my life and spare the others."

Yuan narrowed his eyes at Patriarch Gu and silently pondered.

"Just like the Gu Family from the Lower Heavens, I will give you a chance. Because of your Gu Family, my friends have suffered greatly today, and Xiao Hua even shed tears. I demand compensation. Leave behind all of your treasures and scam. If you walk from this place with even a single treasure on your body, I will finish what I started."

"Thank you for your mercy!" Patriarch Gu wasted no time taking out all of his spatial rings and storage pouches before handing them to Yuan.

"You don't need to give me anything." Yuan said to Gu Xiulan, who was also taking out her treasures.

"Thank you." Gu Xiulan bowed to him.

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Chapter 910 - Sect Master of the Universal Music Academy

Chapter 910 - Sect Master of the Universal Music Academy

After accepting Patriarch Gu's treasures, Yuan took a peek into one of them randomly, and to his surprise, the treasures in this specific spatial ring were all protected by the Gu Family's Destiny Seal.

'The last Gu Family only placed Destiny Seals on their most valuable treasures. Does this mean that Patriarch Gu also carries around his family's heritage? What luck!' Yuan laughed inwardly after realizing this fact.

Indeed, just like the Patriarch Gu of the Lower Heavens, the Patriarch Gu of this world also carries around his family's more valuable treasures, as he believed that it would be safer on him.

After all, who would be dumb and bold enough to rob the Patriarch of one of Seven Legacy Families? Not even a madman would dare do something this bold.

After putting away the treasures he'd just acquired from Patriarch Gu, Yuan spoke in a calm voice, "I have one more thing for you before I leave."

"How did you find out that I would be heading to the Stairway to Heaven? Who told you?"

"The Sect Master of the Universal Music Academy, Sun Hao. He was the one who gave me the information."

"I figured it would be him." Yuan shook his head and sighed.

He then narrowed his eyes at Patriarch Gu, "I was planning on crippling your cultivation base, but since I'd already killed so many experts in your Gu Family, I will spare you from this fate."

"Thank you for your mercy." Patriarch Gu lowered his head.

Although he was unaware, Patriarch Gu's cultivation had already suffered irreparable damage because of the intense fear and stress that he'd just experienced. It may take a few days, maybe even a few months, but his cultivation will eventually collapse on itself.

Sometime later, Feng Yuxiang removed the fire wall around Meixiu and the others.

"Let's go." Yuan said to them, and they continued their journey to the Stairway to Heaven.

The ladies had countless questions for Yuan, but none of them had the courage to ask him, and they preferred to wait until Yuan decided to tell them, so they all remained silent for the rest of their journey.

'Young Master's killing intent just now... It's not something that can be achieved even if he killed people everyday from the day he was born. It requires hundreds if not thousands of years to cultivate, not to mention the amount of people he needed to kill to acquire such killing intent. What do you think, Xiao Hua? Do you have any idea about it? You've been with him the longest, right?' Feng Yuxiang tried to speak with Xiao Hua and Lan Yingying through spiritual sense, but Xiao Hua was not in the mood to chit-chat.

'I don't know. Stop bothering Xiao Hua, phoenix.'

Feng Yuxiang shook her head with a bittersweet smile.

'Do you think it has something to do with his past lives? I have been wondering about this for a while, but when Yuan mentioned his past lives' memories, it sounded like he was talking about memories of more than just one person.' Lan Yingying speculated.

'You think the Young Master has more than just the Divine Paragon's memories? Is that even possible? Having memories of two lives... That's ridiculously heaven-defying if it's real...' Feng Yuxiang said.

'Well, this Yuan that we're talking about...' Lan Yingying said.

'You're right... The Young Master is always like this...' Feng Yuxiang sighed inwardly.

Sometime later, they arrived at the Stairway to Heaven.

"You guys can log off first. I'll climb the Stairway to Heaven when I return from Yu Rou's birthday surprise." Yuan said after putting them down.

"What about you? What are you going to do now?" Chu Liuxiang asked him.

Yuan smiled and said, "I have some unfinished business that needs to be taken care of."

"..."

They had a feeling that Yuan was going to do something dangerous and crazy.

"Yuan... Stay safe, okay?" Meixiu said to him after a moment of silence.

"Of course." Yuan nodded.

"I'll be done before dinner."

After Meixiu, Chu Liuxiang, and Li Jinxi logged off the game, Yuan lifted his head and stared at the blue sky in a dazed manner.

"I warned them that if they tried to hurt my friends again that I'd return and claim their lives. Sect Master Sun, do you really think I am a pushover? I have given you enough chances now. If I don't kill you now, who knows what you'll do once you find out about Wang Ming and the others."

"Feng Feng, do you know the location of the Universal Music Academy?"

"That way." She immediately pointed west.

"Let's go."

Four hours later, Yuan arrived at the Universal Music Academy.

"Sun Hao! Again and again you've pushed my limit! Do you really think that I won't kill you because of your status?! Get out here and accept your punishment!"

Yuan's voice echoed throughout the Universal Music Academy.

A few moments later, hundreds of figures could be seen flying towards him, but Sun Hao was nowhere to be seen.

"Who the hell are you?! How dare you speak of the Sect Master's name in such a disrespectful tone! You're courting death!"

"Do you even realize where you are, brat?"

The disciples of the Universal Music Academy cursed at him.

Eventually, someone there recognized Yuan's face and shouted, "W-Wait! That's the bastard that severed one of the Sect Master's arms!"

"What?! Shit! It's really him!"

"Hahaha! What an idiot to come to our sect! I have been dreaming of avenging the Sect Master! To think I'd get the chance so soon! Today is really my lucky day!"

"Everyone! We're going to offer this bastard's head to the Sect Master when he returns!"

"Yeah! Kill this bastard!"

These disciples were all between Spirit Grandmaster and Spirit Lord, and they all started taking out their instruments.

Yuan rubbed his eyes and sighed, "What a pain in the ass..."

He came here with the intention to take only one life— their Sect Master's life, but at this rate, he'll have to kill hundreds of people before he could even reach Sun Hao.

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Chapter 911 - Confronting the Sect Masters Again

Chapter 911 - Confronting the Sect Masters Again

The disciples of the Universal Music Academy quickly surrounded Yuan after realizing his true identity.

Yuan sighed out loud, "I have already seen enough blood today, so I would prefer it if we can settle this peacefully. I'm only here for your Sect Master. Tell me where he is and I will leave you all alone."

However, the disciples merely laughed at him.

"Haaa..." Yuan sighed again.

"I guess we'll have to do this the hard way..."

He lifted his hand until it was around his neck before he slowly pressed his palm towards the ground.

An unfathomable pressure suddenly enveloped the area, causing all of the disciples there to fall from the sky and slamming into the ground.

[Heavenly Domain]

The disciples tried to get up afterward, but it felt like there was a real mountain on their back, forcing them to continue kissing the ground with their faces.

"This is your last chance to tell me where your Sect Master is. If I do not have an answer within the next three seconds, I will kill everyone here by

turning your bodies into meat paste."

The disciples' faces immediately paled after hearing Yuan's words, and they did not doubt his words for a moment.

"One..."

"The Sect Master is currently at the Spirit Healing Academy!" More than one person there answered a second into Yuan's threat.

"Spirit Healing Academy? What's he doing there?"

"He's trying to heal his severed arm! The other Sect Masters are also there for some sort of meeting! That's all I know!"

"I see. Thank you for your cooperation." Yuan released the disciples from the Heavenly Domain and disappeared from their sight before they could even get back to their feet.

'Spirit Healing Academy... That's where Wang Xiuying is currently studying medicine. Let's give her a visit after I deal with Sun Hao.' Yuan thought to himself as she sped towards the Spirit Healing Academy.

Meanwhile, at the Spirit Healing Academy, all seven Sect Masters of the Seven Spirit Academies gathered in a meeting room.

"I can't believe it. You'd actually manage to reattach Sect Master Sun's severed arm, Sect Master Xiahou." Sect Master Li spoke in an admiring voice.

Sect Master Xiahou shook her head and said, "I was only able to do it because his arm was cleanly severed, and I was able to treat it just in time. If we'd waited even a few more hours, it would've been impossible to reattach it. With that being said, it will take many years of therapy before Sect Master Sun can use that arm properly."

"Even so, I am really thankful for your efforts, Sect Master Xiahou. I'll definitely repay this debt in the future." Sun Hao said to her with a wide smile on his face.

"Anyways, let's get on with today's topic." Sect Master Li said.

And he continued, "As you all have probably heard by now, the Gu Family have assembled over a thousand cultivators and stationed themselves around the Stairway to Heaven. I have already asked them for their reason for such actions. They told me that they were trying to capture a bandit who stole from their family without giving me any more information."

"What do you guys think?"

"Who would believe such bullshit? Nobody assembles a thousand experts for a mere bandit, much less the Gu Family, one of Seven Legacy Families." Bai Enjue sneered.

"I don't believe it either." The others expressed the same sentiment.

Sun Hao, however, remained silent about the issue.

"But if he's not there for a bandit, who— or what is he there for?"

"Do you think the Gu Family could've found a treasure?"

"They would've done something less conspicuous if they were going after a treasure."

The Sect Masters would spend many minutes discussing the issue.

Because they were dealing with one of the Seven Legacy Families, they had to be careful.

"What do you think, Sect Master Sun? You have been awfully quiet this entire time, which isn't common. If you know anything about the situation..."

"I'm not saying anything because I don't know anything," Sun Hao shook his head, and he continued, "Furthermore, whatever the Legacy Families are doing is none of our business."

"That's not true. Although the Seven Legacy Families may have more authority and status than us in general, we cannot just sit still while they could be preparing for war!" Sect Master Xiahou said.

"War? Who would dare go to war with the Gu Family? Some idiot had probably offended them to the extent where they must use such force. The thousand experts they had assembled are most likely just for show." Sun Hao snorted.

Sect Master Li narrowed his eyes at Sun Hao. He could tell that something was off about Sun Hao, but he couldn't pinpoint that something.

Suddenly, all of the Sect Masters there turned to look at the window.

"W-What's this overwhelming presence that's approaching our direction?!" Sect Master Xiahou exclaimed.

"Stay alert and prepare for battle, everyone!" Sect Master Li shouted.

A few seconds later, they could see a figure flying towards them.

"Huh? Wait a second... That's..." Bai Enjue's eyes widened with surprise when he could finally see the face of this individual.

"What's that bastard doing here?!" Sun Hao exclaimed in a shocked voice.

'Why is he here?! What happened to the Gu Family?! He should have encountered them by now!' He cried inwardly.

Yuan entered the meeting room a few moments later through one of the open windows.

"What do you want? I thought our business had already ended." Sect Master Li asked with a profound frown on his face.

"Yes, that was the case. However, one of you decided to push their luck and broke our agreement." Yuan said in a cold voice.

"I warned you. If any of you tries to harm me or my friends again, I would return and claim your lives."

"What?! Are you claiming that we'd tried to hurt your friends after what happened?! That's outrageous!" Sect Master Li exclaimed.

"That's right! Where is your proof?!" Sun Hao shouted.

Yuan narrowed his eyes at Sun Hao, who immediately swallowed nervously.

'Does he know that I had sold him to the Gu Family? No, that's impossible! Patriarch Gu wouldn't sell me out like that! Not to this bastard!' He cried inwardly.

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Chapter 912 - Sect Master Sun

Chapter 912 - Sect Master Sun

"How dare you barge in here and accuse us of such bullshit without any proof! Do you really think you're unstoppable?!" Sun Hao pointed his finger at Yuan and shouted so loud that his saliva sprayed.

Yuan casually dodged the saliva and said, "Proof, huh? That might be a bit difficult."

"See?! I knew it! This guy is just messing with us!" Sun Hao exclaimed.

Sect Master Li then said, "The seven of us haven't even gone anywhere near you or your friends, so where did you get the idea that we'd tried to harm them?"

"I admire your strength, but you've gone too far. Unless you have proof, nobody here will believe you." Bai Enjue sighed.

Yuan smiled and said, "I never said I don't have proof. I just said that it would be a bit difficult."

"What? You have proof?" They looked at him with wide eyes.

"Of course. Do you know of the Gu Family?" Yuan then asked.

"What does the Gu Family have to do with this?" Sun Hao immediately said.

"They're one of Seven Legacy Families. They're not even related to us." Sect Master Li said.

"You see, the Gu Family in the Lower Heavens had tried to harm my friends, so I taught them a little lesson. They didn't like that, so they asked for the Gu Family in this world to avenge them."

"What? Don't tell me that you're the reason the Gu Family dispatched over 1,000 experts..." Sect Master Xiahou mumbled out loud.

"Yes, and they had set a perimeter around the Stairway to Heaven with the intention to ambush me. However, I have never told the Gu Family about going to the Stairway to Heaven, so how did they know that I was going to be there? What a coincidence that I told you guys about my plans to challenge the Stairway to Heaven and the Gu Family found out about it shortly afterward, don't you all agree?"

"I-Is that your so-called proof?! That's just pure speculation!" Sun Hao shouted.

"Sect Master Sun is right. That is not concrete proof. What if they'd found out about it from another source?" Bai Enjue said.

"That's not possible." Yuan shook his head.

"And why do you say that?" Sect Master Li asked.

"Because Patriarch Gu personally told me about the culprit." Yuan said with a cold smile on his face as he narrowed his gaze on Sun Hao.

Seeing Yuan's cold gaze, Sun Hao immediately began sweating profusely.

'Impossible! There's no way that Patriarch Gu would sell me out! He's bluffing!' He cried inwardly.

"And who's the culprit?" Sect Master Li asked.

"The one who's been the loudest since my arrival." Yuan replied.

Everybody there turned to look at Sun Hao, who was soaked in cold sweat as of this moment.

"Sect Master Sun, please tell me that you didn't—" Sect Master Xiahou swallowed nervously.

Out of everyone there, Sun Hao had the most hatred for Yuan, and the other Sect Masters were aware of this even though nobody told them.

"T-That's outrageous! This is a setup! Why would Patriarch Gu even tell you such information?! That's suspicious no matter how you look at it!"

"He had no choice." Yuan calmly responded.

And he continued after releasing some killing intent, "After all, I killed ten of his Spirit Lords and crippled his little army."

"You what?!" Everybody there took a step back after hearing Yuan's words.

"A-Are you insane?! You dare attack a Legacy Family?!" Sun Hao was on the verge of pissing his pants after feeling Yuan's killing intent and hearing about what he did to the Gu Family.

"They were the ones who threatened to harm my friends first. Did you think I would let them do that just because they're one of Seven Legacy Families?" Yuan scoffed.

"And this is mostly your fault, Sun Hao. If you hadn't told the Gu Family about my plans, they wouldn't know where to find me, and I would've left this world without ever meeting them. In other words, I wouldn't have needed to harm them."

Sun Hao suddenly started laughing in a chilling manner, "You're doomed! You're fucking dead! No matter who's at fault here, it doesn't change the fact that you'd attacked the Gu Family! Once the other Legacy Families hear of this, they will also hunt you down! Even if you kill me here today, you're still a dead man! Ahahaha!"

"I don't think that will happen. After all, the Gu Family admitted that they were in the wrong and that they won't pursue the matter any further." Yuan said.

"W-What? I-Impossible!" Sun Hao nearly choked after hearing such information.

"It doesn't matter if you believe it or not. You'll be dead very soon, anyway."

Yuan retrieved the Empyrean Overlord the next second and pointed it at Sun Hao.

"W-Wait! Why don't we all calm down and talk about this?" Sect Master Li stepped forward and said in a nervous voice.

Yuan narrowed his eyes at Sect Master Li, "Talk? We had our talk the last time. Do you really think I am a pushover?"

Sect Master Li sighed, "Even if Sect Master Sun had given information to the Gu Family, he didn't directly harm you or your friends. It was the Gu Family that made such a decision."

"So he did nothing wrong even though he helped someone to harm me, huh? As if I—"

"Die, you little bastard!"

In the middle of Yuan's sentence, Sun Hao suddenly retrieved a long black needle and plunged it at Yuan.

"You—!" The other Sect Masters were shocked and couldn't react in time.

Ding!

However, the needle suddenly stopped in front of Yuan's chest, and no matter how much force Sun Hao put into it, the needle wouldn't move forward.

"W-What's going on?! This is a Divine-grade treasure!" Sun Hao was left confused by the result.

Yuan looked at Sun Hao with an indifferent expression on his face and said, "Treasures below Ancient-grade won't penetrate my Invisible Dragon Cloak's defenses, especially if it's a physical attack."

"Now, die."

Right as Yuan prepared to slice Sun Hao with his sword, a voice resounded in his head, "Allow me to get rid of this trash for you, Young Master."

A small flame suddenly shot out of Yuan's body and attached itself onto Sun Hao's body before it quickly erupted into a massive fire, turning Sun Hao into a burnt corpse within seconds.

'Feng Feng? Why did you...' Yuan looked at Sun Hao's burnt corpse with wide eyes.

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Chapter 913 - Black Anguish Needle

Chapter 913 - Black Anguish Needle

Yuan stared at Sun Hao's burnt corpse with a look of disbelief and surprise. This is the first time one of his servants has killed a cultivator.

"Feng Feng, why did you kill him?" Yuan asked her.

Feng Yuxiang appeared before him with her head lowered.

"Young Master, I apologize for acting on my own, but there isn't any need for you to dirty your hands with these lowlives. If you wish to kill somebody, please allow me to do it for you."

"Furthermore... Young Master, you don't like killing other humans, right? Since I occupy the space in your heart, I know your emotions better than anyone here. Every time you kill someone, your heart clenches slightly."

"However, no matter my reasoning, I have acted without your approval. Please punish me as you see fit, Young Master."

The Sect Masters in the room turned their focus from Sun Hao's corpse to Feng Yuxiang.

'W-Who is this beauty? Where did she come from?'

'This pressure... She's a Spirit King! And a high-level one, as well!'

'Did she just come out of his body?'

They all wondered.

Yuan rubbed his temples and sighed after a moment of silence, "Feng Feng, if I order you to kill someone, how is that any different from killing them myself? I am still the reason they died."

"And I won't punish you. I was going to kill him, anyway. I just wanted to know your reason for killing him, that's all."

"Thank you, Feng Feng, for worrying about me. You're right. I don't like killing others, but there are times when you must act even if doing so will make you feel uncomfortable. If I don't do it, I won't be able to protect those valuable to me— people like you, Feng Feng."

"Also, if I had to choose between dirtying my precious friends in blood or my own hands, I will gladly choose the latter."

"Young Master..." Feng Yuxiang's face flushed with redness when she saw the gentle smile on Yuan's face.

Yuan turned to look at Sect Master Li a moment later and spoke in a calm voice, "Sun Hao just tried to harm me. You all saw that, right?"

They all nodded in silence.

"Then you should have no qualms about me killing him. Do you have anything else to say?"

Sect Master Li walked back to his chair and sat down in an exhausted manner. He took a deep breath and sighed, "I'm sorry. I should've spoken to him right after that incident. None of this would've happened if I had spoken with him."

"Don't blame yourself. People like him won't change so quickly after a single conversation." Yuan shook his head.

"Why are you still here? You've already accomplished your goal, right? Just leave already." Bai Enjue said to him.

"Actually, I still have some business here." Yuan said.

"What? What else do you want from us?"

"Not from you."

Yuan then turned to look at Sect Master Xiahou and said, "You're the Sect Master of the Spirit Healing Academy, right?"

"Eh? Y-Yes, I am..." She nodded nervously.

"Then do you know of a disciple by the name of Wang Xiuying?"

"Wang Xiuying?" She raised her eyebrows in a puzzled manner.

Seeing her reaction, Yuan realized something.

'Oh, right. She's known as Healer Wang in this world.'

"Uhh... I misspoke. Her name is Healer Wang." Yuan corrected himself.

"H-Healer Wang? Why are you looking for her?" Sect Master Xiahou swallowed nervously.

"She's a friend of mine. Since I'm already in her sect, I might as well give her a visit. I also made a promise to see her again when I ascended to Spirit Heaven."

"You're her friend? Why am I not surprised?" Sect Master Xiahou sighed.

'Of course he's friends with Healer Wang. It's like he has a connection with all top geniuses in this world...' She sighed again inwardly.

"Healer Wang is my disciple. I will show you to her residence. Follow me."

She then turned to look at Sect Master Li and continued, "I will be back soon."

"It's okay... I was going to stop the meeting even if you didn't say anything. I have to visit the Universal Music Academy now that their position of Sect Master is vacant... Let's continue the meeting another day. " Sect Master Li sighed.

"Then I will wait for your contact." Bai Enjue said.

Meanwhile, Yuan went to pick up the black needle left behind by Sun Hao.

"I'll be taking this with me. I hope you don't mind." Yuan said to them.

"Do whatever you want..."

None of them wanted to offend him even for a Divine-grade treasure.

[Black Anguish Needle]

[Grade: Divine]

[Quality: Peak]

[Physical Strength Required: 70,000]

[Mental Strength Required: 150,000]

[Description: A needle that contains the deadly poison 'Black Anguish' that will torture its victim with a slow and painful death, rotting them from inside out.]

'What a nasty treasure.' Yuan thought to himself after seeing its description.

Sometime later, Yuan followed Sect Master Xiahou to another location in the sect.

"How's Healer Wang doing in the sect?" Yuan asked her as they traveled.

"Don't worry, she's not being bullied by anyone, if that's what you're wondering," she responded.

Yuan chuckled, "No, I just want to know her situation."

The Sect Master glanced at him with a pondering face before speaking, "Healer Wang is one of the most talented disciples we've had in this sect since its founding. She was a rough diamond waiting to be discovered when she first came here. Once we realized her talent, I immediately took her in as my disciple and taught her everything I knew about medicine and alchemy. That cheeky brat... she just absorbs all of my knowledge like a huge sponge."

"Hoh? She's actually that talented?" Yuan was surprised to hear this since he doesn't know much about Wang Xiuying besides the fact that she sometimes assists her grandfather, Doctor Wang, at his hospital.

However, it was definitely a welcomed surprise.

"We're here."

They landed on a spacious hill where all sorts of plants and herbs could be seen growing at the bottom. On the top of this hill was a large building and a backyard with even more plants, and they seemed more valuable than the ones at the bottom of the hill.

"This is Healer Wang's residence. You can leave whenever. I won't be seeing you out." Sect Master Xiahou left him alone afterward.

Chapter 914 - Revealing His Secret

Chapter 914 - Revealing His Secret

Yuan went to knock on the door after Sect Master Xiahou left him alone.

After waiting for a whole minute without any response, Yuan knocked again.

'Is she not online right now? It is a little late... I guess I'll come back tomorrow morning.'

Yuan logged off after not getting any response for a second time.

When he returned to his own world, Yuan could immediately sense two presence beside him.

"What's the matter, you two?" Yuan asked Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang, who were staring at him like he'd been hospitalized for a long time.

"We should be asking you that, Yuan! Did something happen to you? You can talk to us, you know. We'll always be here to listen to you, no matter what it's about." Chu Liuxiang said to him.

"We've been worried about you, Yuan." Meixiu added.

"Ah... Is this about what happened today?" Yuan sighed with a bittersweet smile.

After pondering for a moment, he nodded, "Alright, I will tell you the truth. You deserve to know the truth, especially if we're going to be spending the rest of our lives together."

"However, I must warn you, what I am about to tell you is going to sound absolutely ridiculous and crazy. This is why I have been delaying this moment. I'm afraid that it might affect our relationship with each other."

The two of them swallowed nervously, anxiously waiting for Yuan to reveal to them his secret.

"Once again, this is going to sound crazy, but I actually have memories of my past lives." Yuan said.

"Huh?"

The both of them muttered at the same time.

"I have memories of my past lives." Yuan repeated.

"W-Wait... Past lives... Are you talking about reincarnation?" Chu Liuxiang asked for clarification.

"Yes."

"I told you guys before that Cultivation Online—the Nine Heavens truly exist somewhere in this universe, right? I know this because I used to live there in the past."

"Tian Chenyu. He was known as the Divine Paragon, bane of demons, and he was responsible for creating the Demon Sealing Clan and most demon sealing techniques out there. I was once Tian Chenyu." Yuan said in a calm voice.

"..."

His partners silently glared at him with wide eyes, seemingly having trouble digesting such information.

After a long moment of silence, Chu Liuxiang spoke in a low voice, almost as though she had a revelation, "That explains why you're able to defeat demons with such ease and why you seem more mature as of lately..."

"W-When did you start recalling these memories?" Meixiu then asked.

"Shortly after I regained my ability to move, I guess." Yuan said.

"Ah, but you don't have to worry about my past lives changing me too much. I am still Yuan at the end of the day, and that won't change. However, I will be lying if I say that it's not taking a toll on me."

"I have only lived 18 years in this life, but in my previous life, I have lived thousands if not millions of years. Although I have only recovered about a thousand years of memories, that is still a lot for someone like me."

Chu Liuxiang suddenly spread her arms and hugged Yuan, even pressing his head against her soft chest.

"You must have endured a lot... If there's anything we can do..."

"Your thoughts are enough. This is a burden that I must face by myself."

"While it's true that we cannot do anything to help you with your returning memories, if you need comfort or feel stressed, we can assist in our own ways." Meixiu said.

"Thank you, you two..."

Sometime later, Chu Liuxiang said, "This makes me wonder if I had a past life, and if I do, what kind of life did I live?"

"I would actually prefer not knowing." Meixiu said.

And she continued, "What if I had some kind of tragic life that I don't want to remember?"

"I guess you have a point..."

Chu Liuxiang then looked at Yuan and asked, "Can you tell us some of your experiences in your past life? Did you have a wife? You lived for thousands of years, right? Surely, you must have had a wife or two!"

Yuan smiled and said, "No, I didn't have anything like that. However, I was engaged."

"You were engaged but don't have a wife? Did something happen?"

"Yes, she died to a demon before we could get married." Yuan said in a calm voice, yet it sounded very lonely and painful.

"S-Sorry... I shouldn't have asked..."

"No, it's fine. What happened was very tragic, but it was something that happened very, very long ago, and I am not Tian Chenyu. Although his feelings remain, I know that I shouldn't become too absorbed in his memories and feelings."

"Anyways, thank you for listening and believing in me." He said to them sometime later.

"I don't know what's crazier. That reincarnation exists or that I've been fighting demons from another world." Chu Liuxiang sighed.

"Another world, huh? Something tells me that Earth used to belong in the Nine Heavens. I'll ask the Lord after I take care of the last demon."

"The Lord?"

"Yes. He promised to tell me about Cultivation Online and other stuff if I take care of the demons for him."

Sometime later, Meixiu went to prepare dinner.

After dinner, Chu Liuxiang eagerly dragged Yuan to the bed and said to him as she stripped naked, "This is the best stress reliever that I know of!"

Yuan couldn't refuse such a tempting offer and gladly accepted it, and they proceeded to relieve themselves all night.

The following morning, after breakfast, Yuan returned to Cultivation Online and tried knocking on Wang Xiuying's door again.

The door opened half a minute later, and a beautiful young lady wearing a green and white uniform stepped outside.

When this young lady saw Yuan's face, her eyes widened with surprise, and a bright smile immediately appeared on her beautiful face.

"Yuan! What are you doing here?!" Wang Xiuying said in a pleasantly surprised voice.

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Chapter 915 - Wang Xiuying's Alchemy Flame

Chapter 915 - Wang Xiuying's Alchemy Flame

"Hello, Xiuying. It's been a while." Yuan greeted her with a smile.

"I happened to be in the area, so I decided to stop by to see you."

However, the smile on Wang Xiuying turned upside down for some reason.

"You're visiting me only because you happened to be nearby? Even though you promised to play with me when you ascend to this realm..." She said with a puffed face, trying to act angry but somehow ended up looking even more charming.

"Yuan, I know that you've been in this world for a while, and you're just visiting me now? I saw you at the Flood Dragon's Scale's Auction, too."

"Sorry, I have been really busy with many things until recently. Honestly, I forgot that you were here until I heard of the Spirit Healing Academy." Yuan said with an apologetic smile.

"Hmph! I can forgive you, but only if you spend the next few days with me," she said.

"Sure. I had planned on staying here for the rest of the week, anyway." Yuan immediately nodded.

"Really? That's great! I will show you around the sect and the things I've learned!" Wang Xiuying immediately cheered up.

"Come inside." Wang Xiuying gestured.

Yuan nodded and followed her into the building.

"What have you been doing lately, Yuan? I haven't seen your name in the announcements for a while." Wang Xiuying asked him.

"Your name used to appear in the sky almost every day— at least that's what it felt like."

Yuan smiled and said, "They were all coincidences. And it's not as though I am actively trying to have my name appear in announcements."

"Maybe you should. At this rate, the world will forget about your name."

"I did not start playing this game because I wanted to be famous, and I still don't care about such things."

"I know, but it hurts me, your number one fan." Wang Xiuying chuckled.

Yuan smiled and said, "It hasn't been that long since I last saw you, but I can tell that you've changed a lot."

"I can say the same to you, Yuan. You look and smell more mature now."

"S-Smell?" Yuan raised an eyebrow, and he started smelling his own arm.

She nodded, "Having a good nose is a trait of a good Alchemist. Thanks to my Master's training methods, my sense of smell has become quite sharp."

"Your Master, the Sect Master of the Spirit Healing Academy?"

"Yes, I will introduce her to you later."

"Sure." Yuan smiled.

"By the way, what does maturity smell like? You can smell it on me, right?" He then asked.

"I don't know how to explain it, but it's a distinct smell that you can easily notice once you understand what the smell really means."

They arrived before a closed door shortly later.

"This is my workshop; it's where I spend most of my time nowadays."
Wang Xiuying said as she opened the door and entered the room.

Yuan followed right behind her.

Inside the spacious room was a large metal pot at the center of the room, but this pot had a very unique shape that Yuan had never seen before. At the end of each side of the room were drawers with labels.

"That metal pot in the center of the room is called a cauldron. It's what Alchemists use to mix medicine and concoct pills."

"The drawers contain all sorts of herbs and medicines that are most commonly used. For the rarer medicine, I have to pick them from the medicine field growing at the bottom of the hill and in my backyard. If I don't have them here, I can request for them from the sect."

"Heh... This is pretty amazing. Is this all a privilege as the disciple of the Sect Master?"

"Only this house and the land it's on is a privilege. I had to grow the medicine field by myself, and I had to raise my rank within the sect to receive support from the sect."

"You got all of this done in such a short amount of time? I'm impressed. In fact, I have been underestimating you. As expected of Doctor Wang's granddaughter. You're a genius when it comes to medicine." Yuan said in a praising tone.

"Hehe..." Wang Xiuying began blushing after hearing Yuan's praises.

"A-Anyway, do you want to watch me concoct a pill?"

"Sure!" Yuan immediately nodded.

"Alright, what kind of pill do you want me to make? I can concoct up to Tier 3 pills at this moment."

"I don't know anything about pills, but something simple is fine."

She nodded, "Then I will concoct a Superior Stamina Enhancing Pill for you. It's a Tier 2 pill that will recover your energy and greatly increase your stamina."

"Sounds good."

"Give me a moment to gather the ingredients."

Yuan watched as Wang Xiuying took out many different herbs from the drawers, putting them all on a long plate in a neat fashion.

She then took a seat in front of the cauldron and patted the space right beside her.

"You can sit here. It's the best seat in the house," she said with a smile.

"Are you sure? Won't I bother you if I sit so close?"

"It will be fine. Trust me."

Yuan didn't say anything else and took a seat right beside her.

"Before I start, I should warn you that it will get a little hot in here even with the windows open. The flame will also be very fierce, but you don't need to worry, since it won't harm you."

Wang Xiuying flipped her hand with her palm facing the ceiling, and with some of her spiritual energy, a ball of green flames appeared on her palm.

"This is called Alchemy Flame. It's a special type of fire that requires a lot of training to control, and even most seasoned Alchemists require years of training to control. Fortunately for me, I have a special physique that makes it incredibly easy for me to control Alchemy Flames."

"There are many types of Alchemy Flames out there, each with its own strengths and weaknesses. Unfortunately, my Alchemy Flame is too weak to have its own name, but once I am capable enough, my Master promised to give me a named Alchemy Flame."

"What a pretty fire..." Yuan mumbled as he stared at the ball of flame floating on Wang Xiuying's palm.

'Hmph! My phoenix fire is countless times more pretty and powerful than her weak-looking Alchemy Flame!' Feng Yuxiang suddenly said, sounding a little unhappy and even jealous for some reason.

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Chapter 916 - Wang Xiuying's Alchemy

Chapter 916 - Wang Xiuying's Alchemy

Seeing Yuan suddenly raise an eyebrow in surprise, Wang Xiuying asked him, "Is something the matter?"

"No, nothing." Yuan showed her a stiff smile, as Feng Yuxiang's comment had caught him by surprise.

After all, this is the first time that Feng Yuxiang has shown such obvious jealousy, and over what? Wang Xiuying's Alchemy Flame? It didn't make sense to him.

"Anyway, I am going to start now. Make sure you watch closely, since people don't normally get to watch me concoct pills, much less have such a view!"

Wang Xiuying suddenly flicked her arm with the Alchemy Flame, sending the green ball of fire flying at the cauldron.

Her Alchemy Flame disappeared into a hole at the bottom of the cauldron, and within seconds, the Alchemy Flame intensified, engulfing half of the cauldron with them.

Yuan felt a heatwave hit him, almost as though he'd suddenly entered a desert, so he subconsciously protected himself with spiritual energy.

A few minutes later, Wang Xiuying spoke, "Now that the cauldron is hot enough, I will begin throwing in the herbs."

She acted upon her own words, throwing the herbs she'd gathered into the cauldron one by one every few minutes without losing control over the Alchemy Flame.

"While I melt the medicine, I must control the strength of my Alchemy Flame so that it doesn't burn the medicine but at the same time burn away the impurities within the medicine."

An hour later, she spoke again, "Now that all of the ingredients are melted, I will intensify the Alchemy Flame, which will solidify the medicine into a pill."

"While the medicine quickly hardens, I must mold it into the shape of a pill, which is perfectly round, like a marble. If I don't mold the pill properly, the pill will come out with inferior quality. And if I do it too slowly, the entire pill will go to waste. This is the most important step when it comes to pill concoction."

A minute later, Wang Xiuying cut the Alchemy Flame completely and went to open the cauldron.

"Brace yourself. There will be a lot of smoke." Wang Xiuying said as she opened the lid, releasing a storm of black smoke.

"It's black because of the impurities. The darker the color of the smoke, the cleaner the pill will come out." Wang Xiuying explained as the black smoke quickly filled the room.

A sudden gust of wind appeared in the room, pushing all of the black smoke outside the window within seconds.

"That wind was caused by a formation in this room. It will quickly clear out the smoke. Anyway, take a look at this pill!"

Wang Xiuying handed him a white pill the following moment.

[Superior Stamina Enhancing Pill] [Tier 2] [Purity: 98%]

[Effects: Greatly boost your stamina by 30% for one hour and recover your used up energy.]

[Description: Concocted by Healer Wang.]

[Limit: Once per hour]

"This is a pretty useful pill." Yuan looked at it with interest.

"How much do you think it'll sell for?" He suddenly asked.

"Eh?! You want to sell my pill already?!" Wang Xiuying looked shocked that he didn't want to keep it.

"It's only out of curiosity. I will be keeping this pill, since it was a gift from you." Yuan said with a smile.

"Well, it honestly depends on the quality of the pill, and most importantly, the person who concocted it. If the person who made it is famous, it will increase the price of the pill."

"I am still a nobody outside, so it will probably go for around a thousand or two gold coins, and that's entirely because of its purity which is above 95 percent."

"However, I am quite popular in the sect, and there are many disciples who want a pill concocted by me, so it could probably fetch for two to three times that price if you sell it in the sect," she continued with a prideful look on her face.

"So do you spend most of your time concocting pills now?"

"Yes, pretty much. I spend about 60 percent of my day concocting pills and the other 40 percent studying. There are so many different types of medicine, herbs, and pill recipes that I must remember, after all."

"You're very diligent, but don't you get bored of sitting in the same spot for hours? I don't think I would be able to enjoy life as an Alchemist even if I have the talent for it." Yuan shook his head.

"It's not boring. Although it might seem like I am just sitting there, I am actually very active, and a lot of things go through my head. As for studying... Well, there's nothing I can do about that. If I don't study, I won't be able to improve."

"Anyways, do you want any more pills? I will concoct as many pills as my idol wants!" She said with an energetic face.

"No, it's fine. One pill is good enough, or it won't feel like a gift anymore."

"I see... Then let me show you around my medicine field before showing you around the sect!"

"Sure." Yuan nodded.

As they prepared to leave the room, someone started knocking on the door.

"Oh, that must be my weekly quota." Wang Xiuying said.

"Weekly quota? You have to work here?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"I don't really need to since I am the Sect Master's disciple, but I asked to do it anyway, since it's good practice for me, and it helps the sect."

Sometime later, Wang Xiuying opened the door to greet the person outside.

"Good morning, Senior Sister Wang." A handsome young man greeted her with a bright smile.

"Morning."

"Here is your weekly..."

The disciple halted his mouth when he noticed Yuan's presence, and his eyes widened with shock.

"There's a man in Senior Sister Wang's living quarters?! Who is this bastard?!" He cried inwardly.

"S-Senior Sister Wang... Who is that?"

Wang Xiuying immediately realized who the disciple was referring to and said with a gentle smile, "He's my precious friend."

When the disciple saw how Wang Xiuying looked at Yuan, his eyes narrowed with hidden killing intent.

Yuan noticed his killing intent and subconsciously smiled in a provocative manner, "Sup."

'T-This bastard!' The disciple silently gritted his teeth.

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Chapter 917 - Medicine Fields

Chapter 917 - Medicine Fields

"What's your name?" The disciple asked Yuan after a moment of silence.

"I won't stay here for long, so you don't need to know it." Yuan calmly responded.

'This bastard's asking for it!' The disciple found Yuan's presence to be even more obnoxious after his response.

Sensing the sudden tension in the air, Wang Xiuying quickly interrupted, "Anyways, tell the elders that I won't be able to complete my weekly quota this week because I will be busy with something else. Sorry you came all this way for nothing."

"I-It's fine. Most people don't even get to see you because you're always holed up in your room. I am already satisfied with seeing your beautiful face this early in the morning, Senior Sister Wang."

"By the way, my Master wanted to ask if you'll be joining the annual competition between Core Disciples tomorrow."

"I'll be there, but I won't be participating, so I'll only be a spectator."

"That's good enough. As long as Senior Sister Wang is there, I will be content. Then I will see you tomorrow." The disciple bowed to her before turning around and walking away.

Of course, he made sure to turn around to look at them, or more specifically, Yuan's face, one last time before disappearing from their sights completely.

"Who was that? Your servant?" Yuan asked afterward.

"No, he's Disciple Gu, a Core Disciple studying under Elder Cang, who is the Sect Master's right-hand man. He's the second most talented disciple in the entire sect. Apparently, he's from a very prestigious family."

"The title of number one disciple in the sect belongs to me, of course!" Wang Xiuying laughed out loud.

'Surnamed Gu, huh? Why do I keep encountering them?' A mysterious smile appeared on Yuan's face.

"Having the second most talented disciple in the sect carry out such a mundane task... He must either be really bored or have too much free time." He said.

"I heard that he'd personally requested to deliver my weekly quota. I don't know the details, but I don't really care either. Anyways, let's visit the medicine field in my yard first. It's the closest and has the most valuable herbs growing."

"Sure."

Yuan followed Wang Xiuying to her backyard, where she started showing him all of the plants that she'd personally grown.

"How long do they usually take to grow? It hasn't been that long since you joined, right?" Yuan asked.

"Most herbs here take less than a month to grow, but if you leave it for longer, the herbs will have a stronger effect, but it will take years, so we usually harvest them after a month. There is actually a secret garden somewhere in this sect with plants that have been growing for hundreds and even thousands of years! I asked to see it before, but I was told that only the Sect Master is allowed to visit the place for security reasons."

Sometime later, they went to the medicine field at the bottom of the hill, which was at least a hundred times larger than the one in her backyard.

"You planted all of these, too?" Yuan was impressed.

There were over 100,000 plants at the bottom of the hill, and all of them were neatly grown and well organized.

"Yes. Besides being time consuming, it's really not that difficult," she said.

The entire tour around the hill took almost three hours.

"Now that we're done with the medicine field, what would you like to see next?" She asked him.

"I don't know anything about your sect, so I will leave it to you."

Wang Xiuying pondered for a moment before speaking, "How about the Alchemy Store? We have one in our sect, and you can even purchase Alchemy Flames there."

"That sounds interesting. Let's go." Yuan nodded.

Wang Xiuying then retrieved a leaf and poured her spiritual energy into it, causing it to grow many times larger.

"This is... a flying treasure?" Yuan raised an eyebrow.

"Yes, since the sect is so vast, I was given this flying treasure to travel around the sect. Come, I'll give you a ride."

"The flying treasure looks like it's only meant for a single rider. I can fly, so you don't need to worry about me." Yuan said.

"Trust me, it'll be fine." Wang Xiuying suddenly grabbed his hand and pulled him onto the flying treasure.

Although it was a little cramped at first, Wang Xiuying made some room by hugging Yuan's body with her own body, "See? We have plenty of space."

She chuckled.

And before Yuan could even say anything, Wang Xiuying controlled the flying treasure, and they flew away from the hill.

While they were in the air, Wang Xiuying purposefully made the flying treasure fly as slow as possible so that they could take their time.

"Look over there. That tall pagoda is the Sect Master's headquarters and also her living quarters. Oh! That building is the cafeteria for disciples within the Inner Court like me. They have some amazing food, but I rarely get the time to go there." Wang Xiuying introduced the buildings to him as they passed them.

Meanwhile, somewhere within the sect, "Master! Do you know anything about the bastard with Healer Wang?!"

After leaving Wang Xiuying's place, Disciple Gu rushed to find Elder Cang for more information on Yuan. He figured that if anyone knew about Yuan's identity, it would be his Master, who is the Sect Master's right-hand man.

"Huh? What are you talking about?" Elder Cang asked.

"I went to give Healer Wang her weekly quota this morning, and I saw this obnoxious man by her side! He was standing inside her living quarters, and he wasn't wearing the sect's uniform, either!"

"Hoh? Healer Wang has an unknown man in her living quarters? This is definitely a surprise, considering her usual behavior. Anyway, I don't know anything about her friend. If he's not a disciple then he must be a guest. Did you check with the administration? All guests are required to sign in."

"N-No... That completely slipped my mind. I will go check with them right now. Sorry for bothering you, Master." Disciple Gu bowed to him before leaving for the Administration Hall, where they keep a list of all visitors.

Chapter 918 - Alchemy Store

Chapter 918 - Alchemy Store

After leaving his Master's side, Disciple Gu rushed to the Administration Hall.

"Good morning, Disciple Gu! How can we help you today?" One of the Elders there welcomed him with a bright and respectful smile.

"I want information on a visitor," he said.

"Of course. Who is this visitor that you speak of?"

"I don't know, that's why I am here. Who is the visitor with Healer Wang?"

"Healer Wang?" The Elder raised his eyebrows, as he doesn't recall recording any guests that came for Wang Xiuying.

"Let me check the log."

The Elder went to grab the guest logbook and brought it back to Disciple Gu.

"This page contains all visitors for the past week, but I don't see any guests mentioning about Healer Wang." The Elder said.

"Let me see."

Disciple Gu grabbed the book and began scanning through all of the names on the logbook.

The logbook contained the guests' names, age, their affiliates, and their reason for visiting the Spirit Healing Academy.

However, there was nobody that came with Healer Wang as their reason for visiting, and Disciple Gu went as far back as one month in the logbook.

"Impossible! Maybe he is actually a disciple and purposefully wore casual clothes to mislead others? What a crafty bastard!" Disciple Gu now believed that Yuan was a disciple of the Spirit Healing Academy all along.

After all, no visitors could possibly enter the sect without going through the Administration Hall.

"Why don't you try asking the Sect Master? If anybody knows about Healer Wang's affairs, it would be her." The Elder suddenly suggested.

"Are you crazy? I cannot possibly bother the Sect Master for something like this! And haven't you heard? The Sect Master of the Universal Music Academy had just been killed! She'll be very busy for a while." Disciple Gu sneered.

"What? Sect Master Sun had been killed? But the Sect Master of the Heavenly Academy said it was an unfortunate accident!" The Elder exclaimed.

"That's just a cover up, obviously. Someone had infiltrated the Universal Music Academy and threatened their disciple that he would kill Sect Master Sun on the same day that he'd died. I heard this from multiple disciples there."

"No way... If the Sect Master Li is willing to conceal the truth, there's a good chance that whoever killed Sect Master Sun is someone that even the Seven Spirit Academies cannot touch. One of the Four Ancient Families, perhaps?"

"By the way, how is your family, Disciple Gu? I heard that they'd also encountered some kind of accident very recently." The Elder asked.

Disciple Gu's face suddenly turned cold after hearing such a question.

"S-Sorry, I overstepped my boundaries by asking about your family, Disciple Gu. Please forgive me." The Elder immediately apologized.

After all, the Gu Family had sustained immense losses with the death of many experts and even 10 Spirit Lords! Their position within the Seven Legacy Families had dropped all the way to the bottom because of this mysterious incident, which shook the entire Spirit Heaven when news spread.

Of course, the death of Sect Master Sun wasn't any less shocking. Even though Sect Master Li announced it as an accident, rumors of it being murder still circulated.

Disciple Gu didn't stay in the Administration Hall any longer and went elsewhere to investigate Yuan's identity.

Meanwhile, Yuan and Wang Xiuying arrived at the Alchemy Store.

The store was a massive pagoda that had 10 spacious floors.

"Look! That's Disciple Wang!"

"G-Good morning, Fairy Wang!"

The disciples at the Alchemy Store immediately recognized Wang Xiuying when they saw her.

"Who's that handsome beside her? He's not wearing our uniform. Is he a guest?"

"Do you think he's Disciple Wang's boyfriend?"

"I saw them hugging each other on the flying treasure before they descended! They definitely have a very intimate relationship with each other!"

The disciples there also took notice of Yuan, who was not only very handsome but also emitted this unfathomable aura, which instantly charmed many female disciples.

"Let's go inside." Wang Xiuying said to Yuan after they landed in front of the Alchemy Store.

Yuan nodded and followed her inside.

"The first, second, and third floor mostly consists of medicine and herbs, so we can go straight to the fourth floor." Wang Xiuying said as she walked straight to the staircase.

Upon entering the fourth floor, Yuan could see many different cauldrons being sold.

"This is where we can buy ordinary cauldrons. The more valuable ones are on the fifth and sixth floor. Sometimes the pills can explode during concoction if you mess up, and the cauldron usually goes with the pill." Wang Xiuying said.

"Isn't it very dangerous to sit so close to the cauldron, then? What if it explodes in your face?" Yuan asked.

"Indeed, it is very dangerous. In fact, the cause of most disciple deaths within the sect is due to their cauldron exploding. However, that will only happen to ordinary cauldrons. There are cauldrons that have been enchanted with safety measures that greatly reduce the risk of injury, but those are way more expensive, and not all disciples can afford that."

"For the record, I have blown up over 100 cauldrons since I have been here! I am also on my 23rd cauldron from practicing Tier 4 pills!" Wang Xiuying said, sounding somewhat proud of it.

Yuan smiled, "And how many times have you died?"

"None! As the Sect Master's disciple, I am only allowed to use the best enchanted cauldrons, so no matter how many I explode, I won't die."

Though, I still get injured by them."

"So if you weren't the Sect Master's disciple, you would've died over 100 times. You're still as reckless as ever." Yuan chuckled.

"Anyways, do you want to get a cauldron while you're here?" Wang Xiuying then asked.

"I don't do Alchemy, though. Why would I need one?"

"Who said cauldrons are only used for Alchemy? You can do other things with them, as well." Wang Xiuying said.

And she continued, "Such as cooking, brewing tea, mixing medicine, and even body tempering."

"Hm? Did you just say body tempering?" Yuan's interest piqued.

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Chapter 919 - Buying a Cauldron

Chapter 919 - Buying a Cauldron

"Yes, you can temper your body in a cauldron if it's large enough to fit your body. Although I have never done it personally, I have heard of people doing that before, and they claim that it has a better effect than a bathtub since cauldrons are specifically made for medicine." Wang Xiuying confirmed.

"I'm more interested in the fact that I can carry the cauldron with me, which will allow me to temper my body wherever and whenever I want." Yuan said.

"Alright, I will get a cauldron."

"Great! Then let's head to the sixth floor. The cauldrons on this floor are too small, same with the cauldrons on the next floor." Wang Xiuying said as she made her way towards the staircase.

Sometime later, they arrived on the sixth floor.

"The cauldrons on this floor don't appear to be big enough to fit my body, either." Yuan said.

In fact, most of the cauldrons on this floor are only large enough to fit a few watermelons, not an adult body.

"That's because these cauldrons can change their size to become bigger or smaller. They're small on display only to save space." Wang Xiuying said.

"Oh... How big can they get?"

"Well, it depends on the quality of the cauldron. Some cauldrons can become as big as an entire house," she said.

"Why would anyone want such a big cauldron?" Yuan raised an eyebrow.

"If you're skilled enough, you can concoct more than one pill at a time. The bigger cauldrons are for those who like to concoct pills in batches, but that is easier said than done. Compared to my Master, who can concoct over 100 pills at once, I can only concoct about 10 pills."

"Anyways, go look around. Since you're my friend, I can probably get you an amazing discount." Wang Xiuying winked at him.

Yuan nodded and began walking around the room.

There were over 100 different cauldrons on display, each of them with a unique shape and color.

Meanwhile, news of Wang Xiuying having a boyfriend began spreading throughout the sect like a wildfire.

"Have you heard? Senior apprentice-sister Wang brought her boyfriend to the Alchemy Store!"

"No way! She's taken?! Since when?! Who is the lucky bastard?!"

"Nobody knows, but he wasn't wearing our uniform, so he might not be part of our sect."

The more people spread the news the more exaggerated and chaotic it became.

"What?! Senior apprentice-sister Wang's fiancé is spending time with her fiancé?!"

"Hey! You know what I heard? Senior apprentice-sister Wang is shopping at the Alchemy Store with her dao companion!"

Disciple Gu eventually got hold of the news, and he immediately began speeding towards the Alchemy Store.

'That bastard was her dao companion?! Impossible!'

Back at the Alchemy Store, Wang Xiuying gave Yuan some recommendations.

"How about this Cauldron of Radiance? Oh, this Nine Oracle Cauldron looks very good, as well!"

Yuan smiled and said, "Does it really matter which one I get? I am only using it to temper my body, after all."

"Of course, it matters! Higher quality cauldrons can make them last longer, and some can even enhance the strength of the medicine!"

Hearing her words, Yuan turned to look at the price tag for some of these cauldrons.

[Cauldron of Radiance: 5,000,000 spirit stones]

[Nine Oracle Cauldron: 7,500,000 spirit stones]

"Do you think I am made out of money? There's no way I can afford these even with a 50 percent discount! And why the hell are cauldrons so dang expensive?!" Yuan exclaimed.

He already has a 5 million spirit stone debt under Feng Yuxiang, so there was no way that he could afford these for now, unless he sold the Gu Family's treasures.

"Alchemy is an expensive career, but it will also earn you a lot of money if you're competent." Feng Yuxiang shrugged.

After looking around the whole room, Yuan found the cheapest cauldron on sale, but even that was worth 1 million spirit stones.

"Stainless Cauldron, huh. Are you sure? I will get the Elder now if you have decided."

Yuan nodded.

"Alright, give me a moment." Wang Xiuying left his side and went to one of the Elders working there.

"Elder, my friend would like to purchase a cauldron." Wang Xiuying said.

The Elder nodded, "The Stainless Cauldron, correct? It will cost 1,500,000 spirit stones because he's not a disciple of our sect."

"What?! I was actually hoping that you'd give him a discount..." Wang Xiuying exclaimed.

"I'm sorry, Disciple Wang, but this is the sect's rule. It's not something that I can change willy-nilly."

"In case you forgot, I am one of only four people in the entire sect that can concoct Tier 3 pills with over 95 percent purity, and I have helped the sect concoct thousands of them! That's worth at least a few hundred thousand spirit stones, yet I never asked for any reward! If I ask my Master, she would definitely give it to me for free! However, I don't want to bother her, so I am asking you to give him a discount instead."

"He is a very important friend of mine, I hope you don't embarrass me in front of him."

"I-I'm really sorry, Disciple Wang. I really want to help you and your friend, but I am a mere Elder. I don't have the authority to make such a decision..."

"Then I will stop concocting pills for the sect." Wang Xiuying suddenly said with a rebellious look on her face, shocking the Elder.

"And when the sect asks why, I will tell them exactly why."

Seeing Wang Xiuying's stubbornness, the Elder felt like crying.

"P-Please, have mercy, Disciple Wang!"

The Elder eventually gave up and said, "I will get the manager... He has enough authority to make a decision."

"Okay." Wang Xiuying didn't say anything else and returned to Yuan.

"What happened? Where's the Elder?" Yuan asked her when she returned alone.

"He'll be here soon," she said with an innocent look on her face.

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Chapter 920 - Phoenix Down

Chapter 920 - Phoenix Down

"What? The Sect Master's disciple threatened to stop concocting pills for the sect if we don't give her friend a discount?" The Manager of the Alchemy Store doubted his ears for a moment after hearing the Elder's words, who was on the verge of crying when he arrived.

"Can you please do something about this, Elder Bei? If Disciple Wang stops concocting pills, the Sect Master will kill us!"

"Calm down, it's just a discount. We can just consider Disciple Wang as the purchaser, not her friend." Elder Bei said.

Sometime later, Elder Bei went to greet Wang Xiuying and Yuan.

"Hello, Disciple Wang and her friend. I have heard the situation. It's just a discount, there's no need for such drastic measures. How does a 75 percent discount sound? Also, there's no need to pay for the visitor's fee, so the total will be 250,000 spirit stones." Elder Bei said to them.

"What do you think? If it's not enough, I can ask them to lower it some more." Wang Xiuying turned to ask Yuan, causing a bittersweet smile to appear on the Elder's face.

"250,000 spirit stones, huh? Do you accept treasures as a payment? I am currently short on spirit stones." Yuan asked him.

"Of course. We accept all sorts of treasures, but we recommend ones that benefit our sect the most, such as herbs and medicine."

"Sounds good."

"Please, follow me to the counter."

Yuan and Wang Xiuying proceeded to follow Elder Bei to the counter.

"Show me what you've got." Elder Bei said to Yuan afterward.

Yuan immediately began dumping out the Gu Family's treasure. Of course, most of these treasures belonged to the Gu Family from the Lower Heavens, as he has yet to remove the Destiny Seals from the other treasures.

"T-That's a lot of treasures..." Elder Bei said. He clearly did not expect such a quantity of treasures from Yuan, and most of them appeared to be Heaven-grade and higher.

Elder Bei also called for someone who can evaluate these treasures.

Sometime later, Elder Bei picked three treasures out of the twenty four treasures and said, "I will sell you the Stainless Cauldron for these three treasures. The total of these treasures will sell for around 275,000 spirit stones, so we'll give you 25,000 spirit stones back. What do you say?"

Yuan pondered for a moment before speaking in a calm voice, "Since you have an expert, I will also let my expert decide. Feng Feng, what do you think?"

Feng Yuxiang appeared beside him the next moment, shocking everyone there.

She ignored their gazes and looked at the three treasures and said, "I can easily get 500,000 spirit stones out of these three treasures."

"E-Excuse me, but who are you?" The Alchemy Store's examiner asked for Feng Yuxiang's background, which is very normal in these kinds of situations where one's qualifications mattered very much.

"You may not know me here, but I owned one of the best stores in the Lower Heavens. With that being said, 15,000 years ago, I operated a store called 'Phoenix Down' in Spirit Heaven. Have you heard of it?" Feng Yuxiang said.

The examiner pondered with a profound frown on his face.

'Phoenix Down...? Why does it sound so familiar?' Elder Bei wondered to himself.

After a few moments of silence, the Alchemy Store's examiner suddenly came to a realization and exclaimed in a shocked voice, "Phoenix Down! I remember now! There is a legend of a store by such a name! According to the legend, it was an immensely popular store that sold all sorts of treasures that could only be found in the Third Heaven and above, and they were all being sold in Spirit Heaven!"

"Furthermore, the owner of this store is a mystery, but rumors say it was a woman with beauty that outshines all treasures in the store!"

"However, the store only operated for a hundred years before it suddenly disappeared."

"Are you telling me that you're the owner of that legendary Phoenix Down?!"

The examiner asked Feng Yuxiang.

Although her beauty was definitely up to standards with the legend, unless she had concrete proof that she was the owner, it wouldn't matter even if she was the most beautiful woman in the Nine Heavens.

"Of course. Here's my certification and license. It expired 15,000 years ago, but it proves that the Phoenix Down existed and that I was the owner of it." Feng Yuxiang retrieved a piece of paper and showed it to the examiner, who started trembling after seeing it.

The examiner then retrieved his own certification and license to compare.

"I-It's real... She's the real deal!" The examiner exclaimed in a shocked voice.

"A-Are you serious?" Elder Bei swallowed nervously.

Why would a legendary figure from 15,000 years ago show up now? Hell, where did she even pop out from?

"I apologize for doubting you, Senior. And it's an honor to meet you." The examiner bowed to her after returning her certification.

Feng Yuxiang silently nodded her head.

"Anyways, if Senior claims the treasures are worth 500,000 spirit stones, then I will not argue." The examiner said to Elder Bei.

"Is that so?" Elder Bei nodded.

He turned to look at Yuan and spoke, "I can give you 225,000 spirit stones and the Stainless Cauldron for these three treasures, or we can give you medicine instead."

"The seventh, eighth, and ninth floor contains medicines from Tier 5 herbs to Tier 5 pills. What do you say?"

Yuan pondered to himself, 'Medicine, huh? This is a good chance for me to stock up some medicine for my body tempering. Even though Feng Feng promised to support me, I cannot rely on her for everything.'

"Let me see what kind of medicine is available first." Yuan said a moment later.

"Very well. I will prepare the spirit stones just in case you decide to take the money instead. As for the Stainless Cauldron, you can take it now." Elder Bei said.

Chapter 921 - Body Tempering Pills

Chapter 921 - Body Tempering Pills

"Follow them just in case they wish to trade more treasures." Elder Bei said to the examiner before leaving them alone.

Wang Xiuying led Yuan to the seventh floor shortly after.

"The seventh floor sells Tier 1 to Tier 2 herbs, medicine, and pills. Since there are too many to display, they have it all listed in a book." Wang Xiuying explained to him after they arrived on the seventh floor, where thick books were displayed instead of the medicine.

Yuan walked over to one of these books and started flipping through them.

'Mind Calming Pill, Body Reforming Pill, Three Spirits Pill, Misty Pill...'

There were over a dozen different pills at glance, and there were hundreds of pages in the book

"Yuan, if you want Tier 1 and Tier 2 pills, I can easily concoct them for you for free. I can also concoct Tier 3 pills with over 95 percent purity. Although I am still learning to concoct Tier 4 pills, I am making fast progress. Give me another month and I will be able to concoct them with 90 percent purity."

Yuan smiled and said, "Thank you, but I don't think I need any pills. However, I am interested in treasures specifically for body tempering."

"There are pills for body tempering, as well. They are called Body Tempering Pills, and a single one of them can last you an entire week. They are also more effective than throwing raw medicine into the bath since pills are mixed better, and condensing them into a pill strengthens its effects.."

"Oh? I'd like some of them." Yuan immediately said.

"Then I recommend Tier 1 Body Tempering Pills first. They're incredibly painful, so I suggest you get used to the weaker ones before using the stronger pills." Wang Xiuying said.

"Don't worry, I am pretty experienced when it comes to body tempering. I'll get a Tier 4 Body Tempering Pill as well as a Tier 5 for today to test their effects."

"T-Tier 4 and Tier 5?! That's insane! Those are only recommended for Spirit Lords and above!" Wang Xiuying exclaimed, unaware of Yuan's cultivation base.

"I'm a peak Spirit Lord." Yuan pointed at himself and said.

"R-Really? B-But it hasn't even been that long since the Mystic Realm, and you were only a Spirit Master then!" Wang Xiuying said.

"I have been consuming valuable treasures and medicine since I entered the sect, and I just entered Spirit Master!"

"Comparing yourself to the Young Master is like comparing Heaven and Earth." Feng Yuxiang sneered.

Wang Xiuying's eyebrows twitched upon hearing Feng Yuxiang's remarks.

'Why does she seem so hostile? Did I offend her somehow?' She wondered inwardly.

"Anyways, I want to test out the Body Tempering Pills today. Once I know what I want, I will return for more."

They proceeded onto the ninth floor to buy the Body Tempering Pills.

After acquiring a Tier 4 and a Tier 5 Body Tempering Pill, Yuan asked, "What's on the tenth floor?"

"Oh, you can buy pill recipes and Alchemy Flames on that floor, but only people approved by the Sect Master can enter that floor." Wang Xiuying said.

"I see..."

"Anyways, is there a place where I can test out my new items?" Yuan then asked.

"You can do it at my house. I have plenty of room, and it's completely free." Wang Xiuying said.

"Sure." Yuan accepted her hospitality without any hesitation.

As they made their way downstairs, Feng Yuxiang would return to Yuan's body.

"Esteemed Guest, we still owe you 100,000 spirit stones. Would you like to retrieve them now?" The examiner said to him.

"Those two pills cost 150,000 spirit stones?" Yuan was speechless.

"Yes, the Tier 4 Body Tempering Pill costs 50,000 spirit stones, and the Tier 5 costs 100,000 spirit stones."

Yuan sighed, "Just keep them for now. I will be coming back later, anyway."

"I understand."

When Yuan and Wang Xiuying exited the Alchemy Store, they were greeted by a massive crowd of disciples waiting outside.

"Wow, why are there so many disciples here today? Is there some kind of special event?" Wang Xiuying mumbled in a dazed voice.

Once the disciples noticed their presence, they began talking to each other.

"Look! That's him!"

"So he's Senior apprentice-sister's dao companion, huh?"

"What? I thought he was her boyfriend! When did he become her dao companion?"

"He's a lot more charming than the rumors... I wish I was in Senior apprentice-sister's shoes right now..." Some of the female disciples there were charmed by Yuan's unfathomable and mysterious aura.

Suddenly, a group of figures walked out of the crowd and stood before Yuan and Wang Xiuying.

"Look! That's Disciple Gu! They're going to confront them!"

"I'm not surprised. Disciple Gu has the hots for Senior apprentice-sister Wang, after all."

"Wait, but why is the Disciplinary Squad following him?"

The disciples understood why Disciple Gu was there, but they cannot imagine why the Disciplinary Squad was there.

After all, they are primarily tasked with dealing with rule-breaking disciples.

"You! Identify yourself!" The Elder leading the Disciplinary Squad stepped forward and pointed at Yuan.

Yuan raised his eyebrows and spoke, "Why?"

"I am the Head Elder of the Disciplinary Squad! Who are you to question me?! I am the law in this place! If I asked you a question, you answer it!"

Wang Xiuying quickly stepped in and said, "Elder, there must have been a misunderstanding. This is my friend, who is currently visiting the sect as a guest."

"So he's not a disciple, huh? You heard her, Uncle Gu." Disciple Gu said to him.

"In this case... Disciple Wang, this 'friend' of yours had snuck into the sect without telling anyone, which is a violation of our sect's rules! He could even be a spy for all we know! And according to the rules of the sect, these violators may be punishable with death!"

"What?! That's nonsense! Elder Gu, my friend is not a spy!" Wang Xiuying immediately refuted.

"We will be the judge of that after we question him." Elder Gu sneered.

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Chapter 922 - Disciplinary Squad

Chapter 922 - Disciplinary Squad

"You want to treat my friend like he's a criminal and question him? I will not allow such a thing to happen!" Wang Xiuying shouted angrily.

"Even if you are the disciple of the Sect Master, you cannot disobey the sect's rules. This man of unknown origin may be a threat to our sect, and as the Head Elder of the Disciplinary Squad, I will not allow anything to happen to our sect. No hard feelings, Disciple Wang. I am merely doing my job." Elder Gu shook his head.

"No! If you take him away, I will stop concocting pills for the sect!" Wang Xiuying said, shocking everybody there.

"Heavens, Senior apprentice-sister Wang is willing to go so far for him... There's no doubt that he's her dao companion!" The disciples were shocked and impressed by Wang Xiuying's boldness before Elder Gu, who is known for being ruthless.

"Senior Sister Wang! Why must you go so far for him? Are you really going to risk all of your hard work in the sect for a guy like him?! Even if you're the Sect Master's disciple, you can still be exiled from the sect for disobeying the sect rules! I will not allow you to make such a sacrifice!" Disciple Gu stepped forward and said.

"Hmph! As if my Master will kick me out of the sect over something like this. And even if I get kicked out, the only reason I joined this sect is because of him!" Wang Xiuying exclaimed, leaving everyone there speechless.

"What? Senior apprentice-sister Wang joined the sect for that guy?" The disciples were in awe of her dedication.

Even Yuan looked at her funny after such a claim.

"You joined the sect for me? But I don't remember asking you to do such a thing..." Yuan said.

"I will explain it to you later." Wang Xiuying said with a rosy face.

Disciple Gu gritted his teeth in anger when she saw Wang Xiuying's blushing face.

'Why does it have to be that bastard?! Why is she not looking at me with those bashful and passionate eyes?! Fuck! I swear I will kill you, or my surname is not Gu!' He cried inwardly.

"Uncle!" Disciple Gu called out to him.

Elder Gu slightly nodded his head and said, "Disciple Wang, if you're going to continue this charade, I will have no choice but to detain you as well! The Sect Master is currently away from the sect, and she might not return for another day or two! Do you wish to spend the next two days behind bars?! Your decision will greatly affect your reputation and position within the sect! Is this how you wish to repay the sect after everything we have done for you?! All for this nameless spy?!"

Wang Xiuying gritted her teeth in anger and shouted, "If that's what I need to do to protect—"

However, Yuan suddenly patted her in the back and interrupted, "I will go with them. They're only going to question me, right? Then I just need to answer them truthfully. There's no need escalate the situation any further or for you to make such sacrifices over such a small thing. I'll be back in a bit."

"Yuan... I'm sorry... If my Master was here, none of this would've happened to you. But don't worry! As soon as she returns, I will tell her to

help you! She won't refuse!"

Yuan smiled, "I also have a feeling that she won't refuse."

He left her side and started walking towards the Disciplinary Squad.

"Cuff him!" Elder Gu said to the rest of the Disciplinary Squad.

Yuan did not resist and allowed the disciples to cuff him with these weird-looking handcuffs made out of some kind of red crystal.

Yuan expected some kind of special effect from the handcuffs, but he didn't feel any different afterward.

"Don't even try to do anything funny. These handcuffs are made out of Spirit Sealing Crystals, which will restrict your cultivation base when worn, so you'll be no different from a mortal without any cultivation!" Disciple Gu said to him with a malicious grin on his face.

"Is that so?" Yuan calmly shrugged, as he could still feel his cultivation base.

This reminded him of the time when he and Wang Xiuying accidentally arrived at the Ancient Dragon City, where they were detained with the same type of handcuffs.

"See you in a bit!" Yuan said while looking at Wang Xiuying.

"Shut up and start moving!" One of the disciples poked Yuan with a stick.

"Poke me again and see what will happen." Yuan narrowed his gaze at the disciple.

The disciple immediately pulled back the stick and trembled in fear.

"Lead the way." Yuan calmly continued.

"Hmph. Arrogant bastard. Let's see if you can keep your cool when Disciple Wang is no longer watching." Elder Gu sneered.

Wang Xiuying and the other disciples proceeded to watch Yuan being led away by the Disciplinary Squad.

After snapping out of her daze, Wang Xiuying retrieved her flying treasure and disappeared from the Alchemy Store.

Sometime later, she arrived at the Sect Master's Headquarters.

Although Sect Master Xiahou wasn't present, there was someone that could contact her in the building.

"Elder Yong! This is an emergency! I need you to contact my Master immediately!" Wang Xiuying started shouting even before the door could fully open.

An old man was sitting at the end of the room, and he lifted his head in a startled manner after Wang Xiuying stormed into his room without knocking.

"Disciple Wang? What happened? I have never seen you this hectic before."

"The Disciplinary Squad took my friend even though he did nothing wrong! Hurry up and call my Master!"

"Your friend?" Elder Yong raised his eyebrows in a questioning manner.

Wang Xiuying quickly explained the situation to him.

"I see... I understand the situation, but your Master is currently in a meeting with the other Academies' Sect Masters regarding Sect Master Sun's death. It would be a bad idea to disturb her now. Let's just wait for her to return in a day or two." He said.

Chapter 923 - Message

Chapter 923 - Message

"That's too long! I need you to message my Master right now! I will not allow my friend to experience such abuse in my sect! If you still refuse, then don't blame me for being dramatic when I leave this sect, since I am clearly not of any value to this sect!" Wang Xiuying said in an angry voice.

"W-What? You're willing to go that far for another person?" Elder Yong was shocked by Wang Xiuying's reaction.

"I will not ask again!" Wang Xiuying took out her sect's medallion and threatened to destroy it.

"Alright! I will contact the Sect Master! Just calm down a bit, Disciple Wang."

Elder Yong sighed as he retrieved a brown talisman and mumbled some words into it.

"Go!"

Elder Yong infused his spiritual energy into the talisman, causing it to fly out the window the next moment, disappearing from the sect shortly after.

The talisman would eventually reach Sect Master Xiahou, who was in the middle of a meeting with the other Sect Masters.

"Should we really be hiding the truth about Sun Hao's death? There's already rumors of it being murder spreading around." Sect Master Xiahou said.

"It's for the best, and it would even save us some face. Or do you want to let the world know that some Junior had killed Sun Hao right before all of us, and that we allowed him to leave without doing anything about it?" Sect Master Li sighed.

"Furthermore, the less people know about Yuan's existence the better."

"How's the Universal Music Academy dealing with their Sect Master's sudden death?" Bai Enjue asked a moment later.

"Not good. Despite my warnings, they're all overflowing with the desire to avenge Sun Hao, and they're even looking for Yuan as we speak." Sect Master Li shook his head.

"What? That's insane! At this rate, the Seven Spirit Academies will be known as the Six Spirit Academies!" The Sect Master of the Steel Lion Academy said.

"Why can't they just find a new Sect Master and not cause more trouble for the rest of us?" The Sect Master of the Lonely River Academy sighed.

Sometime later, Sect Master Xiahou suddenly turned to face the window with a frown on her face.

"What's the matter?" The others noticed her odd behavior and asked her.

Sect Master Xiahou didn't respond immediately and opened the window without getting off her chair, and a moment later, Elder Yong's brown talisman flew into the room and stopped before her.

Sect Master Xiahou recognized the talisman and placed it on her forehead.

Elder Yong's voice resounded inside her head the next moment, "Sect Master, I apologize for bothering you during such a time, but your disciple, Healer Wang, is threatening to leave the sect if I don't send you this message. Anyways, apparently her friend had been escorted away by the Disciplinary Squad for illegally visiting the sect and being a spy, and she wants you to do something about it."

Sect Master Xiahou frowned after hearing the message. It took her a moment to realize the situation because she was focused on Wang Xiuying threatening to leave the sect.

'Hm? Her friend? Illegally visiting?'

The face of a handsome yet terrifying face suddenly appeared in her mind.

"Fuck! Those idiots!" Sect Master Xiahou suddenly cursed out loud as she jumped to her feet, startling the other Sect Masters.

"W-What happened?!" They asked her.

"Elder Gu and the Disciplinary Squad at my sect had detained Yuan, even accusing him of being a spy!"

"What?! Why is he in your sect?!" Sect Master Li asked.

"He's friends with my disciple and wanted to visit her! There was no way I could've refused! However, I didn't tell anybody about it, so they think he'd entered illegally and took him captive!"

"H-Hey... Elder Gu... Isn't he from the Gu Family? Didn't Yuan just kill ten of their Spirit Lords and crippled their army?" Bai Enjue said in a nervous voice.

"Heavens... At this rate, the Seven Spirit Academies will become the Five Spirit Academies!" The Sect Master of the Steel Lion Academy said.

Sect Master Xiahou began sweating profusely after hearing such words.

"I-I'm sorry, but I have to return to my sect! Please excuse me!" Sect Master Xiahou retrieved her flying treasure and immediately began speeding back to the sect.

"We should probably postpone our meetings until that man has left this realm..." Sect Master Li sighed.

"Hey, since someone from the Gu Family is involved, shouldn't we notify Patriarch Gu?" The Sect Master of the Lonely River Academy said.

Sect Master Li nodded, "I'm sure they'll appreciate it."

He retrieved a talisman and mumbled to it before sending it flying towards the Gu Family's direction.

Ban Enjue then said, "I'm going to follow Sect Master Xiahou. If the Universal Music Academy learns of his location, they will mostly try to avenge Sun Hao and attack him."

"I'll go with you."

"Me too."

Thus, the other Sect Masters there began making their way to the Spirit Healing Academy while praying that nothing too serious will happen from this incident.

Meanwhile, outside the Alchemy Store, after the Disciplinary Squad took Yuan away, some of the disciples there spoke, "Is it just me or does Senior apprentice-sister Wang's dao companion look familiar? I'm pretty sure that I have seen him before, but I cannot remember when and where."

"You too? I also thought the same when I saw his face."

"W-Wait! I remember! Wasn't he the one who severed the Universal Music Academy's Sect Master's arm during the disciple examination?! That was him in the broadcast, right?!"

"Now that you mention it..."

"Holy shit! Didn't their Sect Master die yesterday? Rumor has it that he was murdered by the person who severed his arm!"

"What! I thought he'd died in an accident!"

"I don't like where this is going..."

While news of Yuan's presence spread throughout the sect like wildfire, Yuan himself followed the Disciplinary Squad and Disciple Gu to some isolated area within the sect.

They eventually arrived before a suspicious-looking cave that looked like the entrance to a dungeon.

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Chapter 924 - Underground Prison

Chapter 924 - Underground Prison

"Is this place your headquarters? Judging by the outside appearance, I dare say that your Disciplinary Squad doesn't have a decent budget if any at all." Yuan chuckled.

"Shut up and go inside." Elder Gu said to him.

Yuan shrugged and entered the cave, which led him to an underground prison that looked like it had been out of service for hundreds of years.

'Young Master, should I just kill these ignorant and disrespectful fools?' Feng Yuxiang asked him.

'No, leave it. I want to see what they're going to do.' He said.

He then said out loud, "Hey, I am only being questioned, right? Must we do it here? It's so dirty that I can feel myself getting sick just from breathing in the air."

Disciple Gu started laughing after hearing Yuan's words, and he said afterward, "You really think we took you here to question you? Just how dumb are you?"

"What? If you're not going to question me, why did you bring me here?" Yuan asked, continuing his act.

"Oh, we'll question you all right. The question is how we'll do it!" Disciple Gu retrieved his sword and pointed it at Yuan.

"I don't care who you are. Since you dared to lay your filthy hands on my woman, I will make you regret ever being born!"

Yuan's eyes widened with surprise, and he asked, "Huh? When did I ever lay a hand on your woman?"

"Don't act dumb! Healer Wang is my woman! I have had my eyes on her ever since she entered the sect, and I will do everything and anything to get my hands on her!" Disciple Gu shouted.

However, to their surprise, Yuan started laughing.

"What's so damn funny?"

"Everything." Yuan smiled.

"I see. So you still don't understand your current situation, huh? Don't worry, I will help you come to a realization very soon!" Disciple Gu began approaching Yuan, but he was stopped by Elder Gu.

"Uncle?"

"Wait. There's no need to be impatient. I still need to question him. Once I am done, you can have all the fun you want with him." Elder Gu said.

"Chain him to the wall!" He commanded the other disciples.

Yuan didn't resist and allowed them to chain him to the wall in one of the prison cells.

"If you're smart, you will answer my questions truthfully." Elder Gu stood before him and began questioning him.

"What's your name?"

"Yuan."

"What's your relationship with Healer Wang?"

"We're only friends."

"What is your background?"

"I don't have one."

"Which sect do you belong to?"

"I'm what you call a Rogue Cultivator. I don't belong to any sect at this moment."

"What about your family?"

"They threw me out for being useless."

"In other words, you're a nobody! Which means we can kill you without offending anyone. You can forget about ever leaving this place now!" Disciple Gu laughed out loud.

"What about Healer Wang? She'll be sad and angry if you kill me." Yuan asked.

"Don't worry about her. She'll forget about you once we feed her a Mind Invasion Pill."

"A what?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

'Young Master, a Mind Invasion Pill can alter one's memories, and that includes erasing their memories.' Feng Yuxiang explained.

"A soon-to-be-dead man doesn't need to know." Disciple Gu said with a grim smile on his face.

"How did you sneak into the sect?" Elder Gu continued to question Yuan.

"I flew in here... With your Sect Master." Yuan said with a smile.

"What?" Elder Gu immediately frowned.

"You heard me."

"You know the Sect Master?"

"Not just the Sect Master. I also happen to know your Patriarch— Patriarch Gu. We're practically best friends."

"He's fucking with us!" Disciple Gu exclaimed.

"If you don't believe me, you can contact your Patriarch and ask him yourself. Just tell him my name. He knows it very well."

"Shut your damn mouth!" Disciple Gu suddenly rushed into the cell and swung his sword at Yuan, who was defensively chained to the wall.

"Wait!" Elder Gu tried to stop his nephew, but Disciple Gu was too fast, and the sword in his hand was already in a swinging motion.

"Don't worry, I won't kill you so quickly! However, I will take one of your limbs!" Disciple Gu laughed as his sword mercilessly chopped at Yuan's right leg.

Ding!

The sound of metal colliding resounded, and it felt like he'd struck a block of steel with his sword for Disciple Gu.

The sword flew out of his hand almost instantly after attacking Yuan, landing a few meters away.

"W-What the fuck?" He muttered in a dumbfounded voice.

"Surprised?" Yuan asked him with a smile.

"You'll need a little more arm strength if you want to take my leg."

"I-I don't know what kind of trick that was, but you're still chained to the wall! What can you do in such a state? And the longer it takes to kill you, the more I will enjoy it, so resist as much as you want!"

Yuan suddenly yanked his arm, ripping the chains off the wall.

He then snapped the handcuffs into two parts with ease.

"What were you saying?" Yuan looked at Disciple Gu with a nonchalant expression on his face.

"I-Impossible! Those handcuffs are made from Spirit Sealing Crystals! Did he break them with his raw strength?!" The other disciples exclaimed.

"You don't believe that I know your Patriarch, right? If that's the case, then how come I have this in my possession?" Yuan retrieved one of the treasures he'd acquired from Patriarch Gu and showed it to them.

"T-That's—! Impossible! Why do you have that?!" Elder Gu exclaimed in a baffled voice.

"That's definitely one of our Gu Family's heirlooms—the Grail of Truth! I can even sense our Destiny Seal on it!" He cried inwardly.

"If you want to know how I got this treasure, go ask your Patriarch. He was the one who gave it to me, after all." Yuan said with a mysterious smile on his face.

Meanwhile, Sect Master Li's talisman arrived at the Gu Family's residence, alerting them of the situation at the Spirit Healing Academy.

Chapter 925 - Release Him!

Chapter 925 - Release Him!

"P-Patriarch Gu, you have a message!" The person who acquired Sect Master Li's message went to find him.

"What is it?" Patriarch Gu was immediately annoyed.

After his immense defeat and embarrassment caused by Yuan, Patriarch Gu has become easily irritable, so much so that even the slightest annoyance would cause his brows to frown and his blood to boil.

"T-The Sect Master of the Heavenly Academy has sent us a message," said the person with the talisman.

"Sect Master Li? What does he want from us? If this is about what happened recently, just ignore it." Patriarch Gu said.

"No... This is different. Although I don't understand the message, the Sect Master sounded a little nervous." The person handed the talisman to Patriarch Gu.

Patriarch Gu sucked his teeth in an annoyed manner and activated the talisman.

Sect Master Li's voice resounded in his head the next moment, "This is Sect Master Li of the Heavenly Academy. Something has happened within the Spirit Healing Academy that you should probably be aware of, considering what happened to your family recently. Elder Gu, who is the head of the Disciplinary Squad, has taken Yuan captive and is currently questioning him. You should know first hand what happens if you offend Yuan, hence this message."

"Fuck! This damn little brother of mine! Why is he messing with the one person he shouldn't mess with?! And so soon after what happened between the Gu Family and him!" Patriarch Gu tossed the talisman at the wall in an angry manner.

"I'm going to visit the Spirit Healing Academy! Hopefully, I won't be too late to save his pitiful life!"

Not daring to waste anymore time, Patriarch Gu flew towards the Spirit Healing Academy on his flying treasure.

Meanwhile, Sect Master Xiahou returned to the sect.

"S-Sect Master? What happened to the meeting?" Elder Yong was surprised to see the Sect Master return so quickly.

"Where's my disciple?!" She asked him, her appearance all messed up from the rush.

"She went to the Disciplinary Squad's headquarters after I sent you the message," he said.

"Anyways, what's this all about?"

"I don't have time to explain! Thank you for sending me the message!"

Sect Master Xiahou didn't explain any further and rushed to find Wang Xiuying.

"Looks like the Spirit Healing Academy is still intact... thankfully..." Bai Enjue said after the rest of the Sect Masters arrived at the sect.

At the Disciplinary Squad's headquarters, Wang Xiuying was arguing with the disciples working there.

"Where did you take my friend?! The Sect Master is aware of the situation, and it will only be a matter of time before she returns! If you let my friend go, I will not press charges against you!" Wang Xiuying said.

"P-Please calm down, Senior apprentice-sister Wang... We have no idea what you're talking about... What friend?" The disciples at the headquarters were completely clueless.

"Nonsense! Your leader, Elder Gu, took my friend in for questioning! I saw it with my own eyes, as did many other disciples! You won't be able to cover for them!"

"Why would we lie to you, Senior apprentice-sister Wang? It's true that Elder Gu had left with some disciples sometime ago, but they haven't returned since then, and nobody seems to know where he's gone." The disciple at the counter said, feeling an urge to cry.

"Are you serious? Then where did they take my friend?!" Wang Xiuying exclaimed.

"I'm sorry, but I wish we knew." They all shook their heads.

"Then do you know where they could've taken my friend?" Wang Xiuying did not give up and continued to pressure them.

Sometime later, Sect Master Xiahou arrived at the Disciplinary Squad's headquarters.

"Sect Master!"

All of the disciples there greeted her the moment they noticed her presence.

"M-Master! You're back!" Wang Xiuying rushed to her Master with a relieved expression on her face.

'Now that Master is here, they will have no choice but to release Yuan!'

"Master! They called my friend a spy and took him in for questioning when he did nothing wrong!" Wang Xiuying made sure to put on the most desperate and unhappy expression she could possibly make while asking for her Master's help.

"This friend of yours... Is he a young man named Yuan?" Sect Master Xiahou asked her, silently hoping to herself that Wang Xiuying had another friend besides Yuan.

"Y-You know my friend, Yuan? How do you know each—I mean, yes! My friend, Yuan, was taken by Elder Gu and the Disciplinary Squad!" Wang Xiuying nodded her head viciously.

The frown on Sect Master Xiahou's face deepened, and she immediately approached the disciples working at the front desk.

"Release him right this moment!" She said to them in an angry and demanding voice.

However, nobody there moved.

"Did you not hear me?! I will not repeat myself!" She roared, causing them to tremble in fear.

"S-Sect Master! It's not that we don't want to release him... We don't even know where he is! Elder Gu hasn't returned since he left, and there's nobody in our cells right now! You can even check for yourself!" The disciples there explained the situation to her.

"What? How is this possible?" Sect Master Xiahou frowned.

'Damn it! What the fuck are you doing, Elder Gu?! Are you trying to destroy our sect?!' She cried inwardly.

"If he's not here, then hurry up and contact him!" Sect Master Xiahou shouted after snapping out of her daze.

"W-We've tried that as well, Sect Master! Elder Gu isn't answering his communication jade slip, either!"

"FUCK!" Sect Master Xiahou slammed her fist into the desk before her, shattering it into countless pieces, shocking everyone there, including Wang Xiuying.

"M-Master? Let's all calm down a little..." Wang Xiuying said, feeling completely baffled by her Master's outburst.

After all, Yuan was her number one idol, friend, and patient, yet she wasn't anywhere as outraged and emotional as her Master.

"CALM DOWN?! Do you have any idea who they're messing with?! That crazy monster dared to kill Sect Master Sun in front of the other Sect Masters for trying to hurt his friends! He will destroy our sect at this rate!" Sect Master Xiahou exclaimed.

"W-What...?"

Everyone there was left speechless by the Sect Master's outrageous claim.

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Chapter 926 - Answer My Question or Die!

Chapter 926 - Answer My Question or Die!

"W-What did you just say? Yuan killed the Sect Master of the Universal Music Academy...?" Wang Xiuying stared at her Master with a look of disbelief on her face.

"There must have been some sort of mistake, Master. Yuan isn't the type to kill another person. He's really kind and gentle. I doubt he would even hurt a fly..."

Sect Master Xiahou looked at Wang Xiuying and frowned, "Are you sure we're talking about the same 'Yuan'? I watched him kill Sun Hao with my own eyes. Of course, it wasn't as though Sun Hao was completely innocent."

"Holy shit... Senior apprentice-sister Wang's friend is responsible for Sect Master Sun's death? I heard of the rumors, but to think that it was actually true..." The disciples there were shocked to learn the truth.

"We can talk about this later! We need to find them right now before it's too late!" Sect Master Xiahou suddenly said.

"Sect Master Xiahou, what's the current situation?" The other Sect Masters finally caught up with her and asked.

"What are you guys doing here?" Sect Master Xiahou asked them with a surprised face.

"We're here for insurance. All of our sects rely on the Spirit Healing Academy for pills and medicine, so we cannot allow it to fall so easily. " Sect Master Li said.

Although the Spirit Healing Academy is the weakest in the alliance in terms of prowess, they're actually the most important. Without the Spirit Healing Academy, the other sects will have to spend much more money on pills and other medicine.

Sect Master Xiahou proceeded to explain the situation to the other Sect Masters.

"What?! You cannot find them?! How is that even possible?"

"I really don't know what's going on." Sect Master Xiahou shook her head.

She turned to look at Wang Xiuying and asked, "Can you tell us exactly what happened before Elder Gu took him away?"

Wang Xiuying nodded and recalled everything from the moment she met Yuan to the moment they left the Alchemy Store, where the Disciplinary Squad showed up.

"What? Disciple Gu is also involved in this mess? If we cannot contact Elder Gu, maybe we can contact Disciple Gu through his Master, Elder Cang." Sect Master Xiahou said.

They left the Disciplinary Squad's headquarters shortly after and went to find Elder Cang, Disciple Gu's Master and Sect Master Xiahou's right-hand man.

Sometime later.

"Sect Master— and other Sect Masters?! Why are all of you here? What happened to the meeting?" Elder Cang was shocked to see them gather inside his room.

"Elder Cang, I need you to contact your disciple right now!" Sect Master Xiahou said to him.

"My disciple? Which one?" Elder Cang raised an eyebrow.

"Disciple Gu!"

"Gu Zhiting? Did he do something? For the Sect Master to be asking for him... If he did anything wrong, I will personally lecture him when he returns—"

"WE DON'T HAVE THE LUXURY TO WAIT! HURRY UP AND CONTACT HIM!" Sect Master Xiahou suddenly roared at him.

Elder Cang nearly had a heart attack. Although this isn't his first time being yelled at by her, it was never this severe.

'Gu Zhiting, what in heavens' name did you do to anger the Sect Master to such an extent?! Even the other Sect Masters are here! Fuck me!' Elder Cang cried inwardly as he retrieved his communication jade slip and called Disciple Gu.

Meanwhile, back at the underground prison, a few moments after Yuan broke out of his restraints, Disciple Gu felt his communication jade slip trembling.

"U-Uncle, it's my Master... He's calling for me for some reason..." Disciple Gu said to him.

"Ignore it! We have more important things to deal with right now!" Elder Gu quickly said.

Yuan smiled and said, "Go ahead and answer it. I'm sure it's very important. Don't worry, I won't do anything. I promise."

"Shut up! Nobody asked for your input!" Disciple Gu shouted.

Yuan shrugged, "Suit yourself."

"Answer me! Where did you get that treasure?! If you don't answer me right now, I will kill you where you stand!" Elder Gu suddenly roared, and he released his cultivation base that was at the first level of Spirit King.

"Are you sure you want to do that here? The ground will collapse on us if you act too crazy." Yuan said in a calm voice.

"I will not repeat myself! Answer my question or die!"

However, instead of answering Elder Gu's question, Yuan retrieved another treasure that belonged to their Gu Family.

"T-That's—!"

Even Disciple Gu recognized the treasure this time.

"BASTARD! HOW DID YOU ACQUIRE THOSE TREASURES?!" Elder Gu was fuming so hard that his entire face was covered in bulging vessels that could pop at any moment.

"Go ask your Patriarch." Yuan smiled.

"THEN DIE FOR ME!"

Elder Gu could no longer endure his anger and released his cultivation base at Yuan.

BOOM!

The entire underground collapsed from the attack, but neither Elder Gu nor his people were harmed, as they were protected by his spiritual energy.

Meanwhile, back at the sect, Elder Cang shook his head, "I have tried contacting Gu Zhiting many times, but he's not answering."

"Fuck!" Sect Master Xiahou cursed again.

It was at this moment everyone in the room suddenly sensed a ripple in the air that was caused by Elder Gu's powerful attack.

"Did anyone feel that just now?! Someone is fighting nearby!"

"Judging by the strength of the ripple, it was caused by a Spirit King! The only Spirit King beside us in this place is Elder Gu!" Sect Master Xiahou said.

"Let's go!"

Everybody there immediately rushed out of the building and followed the direction the ripple was coming from.

They arrived at the collapsed cave a few minutes later, and when they arrived, Elder Gu and the others were still at the scene, as they wanted to make sure that Yuan was dead before they left.

"Elder Gu! What is the meaning of this?!"

"S-Sect Master?! What are you doing here?!" Elder Gu had the same reaction as Elder Cang, but he was more nervous.

But before Sect Master Xiahou could even respond, another person showed up to the scene.

"Elder Brother?!"

"F-Father?!"

It was Patriarch Gu, and he had a terrified look on his face.

Chapter 927 - Grail of Truth

Chapter 927 - Grail of Truth

"Patriarch Gu? What is he doing here?" The other Sect Masters were surprised to see him as well.

However, Patriarch Gu ignored all of their gazes and focused on the collapsed cave with a terrified look on his face.

He then looked at Elder Gu and Disciple Gu.

"You... What have you two done?" He asked them in a low and dispirited voice.

"Elder Brother! I just took care of some bastard that had stolen our Gu Family's treasures! Believe it or not, he had our Grail of Truth and—"

"YOU FOOL!" Patriarch Gu roared.

"Did you not hear about what had happened to our family?! Did you really think that we'd encountered a calamity?!" Patriarch Gu pointed at the collapsed cave and continued, "The person you just buried was that calamity!"

"W-What? Are you saying that he was the one who crippled our family and killed our Spirit Lords? If that's the case, then I have avenged our family! He's dead!" Elder Gu laughed out loud.

"You really think you had killed him?" Sect Master Li suddenly spoke, and he continued, "Even six Sect Masters from the Seven Spirit Academies was not enough to defeat him."

"What?" Elder Gu and Disciple Gu looked at the Sect Master with wide eyes.

BOOM!

The ground suddenly shook, and before anyone there could react, almost as though a volcano had erupted, the collapsed cave suddenly exploded into the air.

A figure could be seen flying out of the rubble a moment later.

Of course, it was Yuan, and he was completely unharmed.

"Y-Y-You!" Elder Gu stared at Yuan with a shocked look on his face.

'How did he survive my attack?! I used all of my cultivation in that attack!' He cried inwardly.

"Hm?" Yuan quickly noticed that there were more people than before.

He glanced at them and smiled.

"Yuan! Are you okay?!" Wang Xiuying asked him while standing behind the Sect Masters on her flying treasure.

"Yes, I am fine. However, believe it or not, these guys just tried to kill me! I was so scared!" Yuan chuckled.

"Yuan! Listen to me!" Sect Master Xiahou suddenly spoke, "What happened between you and Elder Gu and Disciple Gu has nothing to do with my Spirit Healing Academy! I came back as soon as I heard about it! Please, forgive us!"

"In fact, I hereby strip them of their statuses and exile them from my sect! They no longer have anything to do with us!"

"What?! You can't do that to us, Sect Master!" Disciple Gu exclaimed in a shocked voice.

Yuan nodded, "Don't worry, I never planned on doing anything to your sect. After all, my friend is studying there. Furthermore, I am not so unreasonable that I would punish an entire sect because of two peoples' actions."

He then turned to look at the Disciplinary Squad and continued, "Since you guys were only following orders, I will also forgive you. Now get out of here before I change my mind."

The disciples following Elder Gu immediately turned around and started running back to the sect.

Once it was just Elder Gu and Disciple Gu, Yuan turned to look at them and mumbled out loud, "Now, what should I do with them?"

"Not only did you plot to kill me just because I am friends with Healer Wang, but you also planned on feeding her a Mind Invasion Pill to alter her memories. It wouldn't be unreasonable to kill the both of you, right?"

"What?! They wanted to feed me the Mind Invasion Pill?!" Wang Xiuying exclaimed in a terrified voice after hearing this information.

"You two... I'm speechless..." Even the other Sect Masters were baffled to hear such information.

"P-Please wait!" Patriarch Gu suddenly shouted.

And he continued, "I know they have wronged you, but please, can you spare their lives?! I—the Gu Family will compensate for this incident! We will give you anything you want! Gu Zhiting is my only son, and that foolish young brother of mine is the only brother I have! If you kill them, I will truly have nothing left!"

Yuan turned to face Patriarch Gu, who had a desperate expression on his face.

"You want me to forgive them after everything today? What do you think happened when I forgave Sun Hao? He immediately ignored my warning

and spat on my kindness by going to your Gu Family."

"If I forgive them after everything they've done, they will definitely come back to bite me in the future, and I cannot risk doing that." Yuan said in a cold voice.

"I-It won't happen! I promise! I swear on my surname that they will not trouble you ever again in the future!"

Yuan turned to look at Elder Gu and Gu Zhiting, who were completely soaked in sweat.

"Tell me. If I forgive you, will you promise to never bother me or Healer Wang ever again?" He asked them in a calm voice.

"W-We promise! We will never bother you or Healer Wang ever again!" They both promised simultaneously.

"..."

Yuan silently stared at them with a pondering look.

After a moment of silence, he turned to look at Patriarch Gu and smiled.

Patriarch Gu subconsciously smiled back.

"What a pity." Yuan suddenly said as his expression turned cold.

"W-What?" The smile on Patriarch Gu's face immediately flipped upside down.

Yuan revealed a certain treasure to them.

"T-That's—!" Patriarch Gu's eyes widened with shock.

"That's right. It's the Grail of Truth. As long as I have this, you cannot lie to me." Yuan said.

[Grail of Truth]

[Grade: Divine]

[Quality: Peak]

[Description: A powerful treasure once owned by the Sacred Temple of Truth. The Grail of Truth will expose all liars and emit a golden glow when someone lies before its presence.]

The Grail of Truth before them was glowing, meaning that someone had lied just now, and the only people that had the chance to lie were Elder Gu and Gu Zhiting.

"W-Wait! Give us a chance to explain!" Elder Gu immediately shouted.

"I already gave you both plenty of chances, and unfortunately, you just used up your last chance." Yuan said in a nonchalant manner.

"H-Help me! Father, I don't want to die!" Gu Zhiting began crying with a runny nose.

"Please! You can even take away their cultivation! Just spare their lives!" Patriarch Gu pleaded.

However, Yuan pretended to not hear their voices and retrieved the Empyrean Overlord, his intentions clear.

The Sect Masters distanced themselves, as they did not want to be caught up in their mess.

Patriarch Gu wanted to stop Yuan, but he was afraid that by doing so, Yuan would take his anger out on him and his Gu Family afterward.

Therefore, he could only use his voice to beg for their lives.

Unfortunately, Yuan had no intentions to spare them.

"Here's a suggestion for your next life— stay out of trouble!" Yuan said to them as he swung the Empyrean Overlord, sending a powerful wave of Sword Aura at them.

Elder Gu and Gu Zhiting were so terrified by the pressure that they couldn't even defend themselves.

And right as the Sword Aura was about to hit them, a figure suddenly appeared before them like a ghost and blocked the attack.

Yuan raised an eyebrow after seeing this newcomer with a face that he didn't recognize.

Although Yuan didn't recognize this person, the Sect Masters and Patriarch Gu recognized him.

"Lord Ji?!" The Sect Masters exclaimed in a surprised manner.

However, Patriarch Gu appeared to be more relieved than surprised, almost as though he was expecting this person to appear.

This newcomer known as Lord Ji narrowed his eyes on his own arms after blocking Yuan's attack, feeling a little numb because of it.

"Who are you?" Yuan asked him in a calm voice.

"Hello, young man. I am known as Lord Ji, and I am the current Lord of this realm. My Ji Family oversees the Nine Heavens— At least up to the Fourth Heaven."

"Lord of Spirit Heaven?" Yuan mumbled.

He recalled such a thing being mentioned before— that every world besides the Lower Heavens will have a 'Lord' that oversees it.

"Because of my status, I don't normally intervene in conflicts that don't greatly affect the balance of the world."

"So me killing these two will somehow greatly affect the balance of this world?" Yuan asked.

"No, it won't."

"Then why are you here?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"Because a friend of mine asked for help." Lord Ji responded with a calm smile on his face.

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Chapter 928 - Lord Ji

Chapter 928 - Lord Ji

"A friend, huh?" Yuan glanced at Patriarch Gu, who looked much better than before in terms of appearance, almost as though he'd been resurrected.

Lord Ji smiled and said, "There's no point in hiding the truth. Indeed, it was Patriarch Gu who asked me for help."

"And to tell you the truth, I have been watching you ever since you came out of the Stairway to Heaven, Yuan."

"Huh? You have been stalking me since I came to Spirit Heaven?" Yuan was surprised to learn this information, even a little creeped out by it.

Lord Ji laughed out loud, "No, I wouldn't call it stalking. I didn't physically watch you with my own eyes— I simply gathered information about you."

"You had piqued my interest, so I wanted to know more about you— to understand you. Unfortunately, I still cannot understand your existence even as we speak. Your background is a complete mystery, almost nonexistent, almost as though you'd suddenly popped into this world."

"Tell me, where did you come from?" Lord Ji narrowed his sharp eyes at Yuan.

Yuan remained calm and said, "Sorry, but I don't have the time to chit chat with you."

"Then when will you have time?"

"I will think about it after I kill those two behind you."

Lord Ji's eyes widened, and he proceeded to speak in a surprised voice, "You still have thoughts about killing them even though I am clearly trying to protect them? No one has ever dared to stand up to me like this— not even when I was little."

"Of course. They tried to kill me and harm my friend, and they clearly won't stop even if I forgive them today."

Lord Ji sighed, "Why don't you give me some face today and let them go, Yuan? I promise you that I will make it worthwhile. Nothing good will come out of going against my Ji Family. Let's just be friends with each other, okay?"

Yuan sneered at his words and spoke, "Unfortunately, I don't want to be friends with someone who is willing to protect these good-for-nothing that wouldn't think twice before plotting against others."

"I don't care if you're the Lord of this realm or if your family oversees the Nine Heavens. Nothing will stop me from killing these two today."

The friendly smile on Lord Ji's face disappeared after he heard Yuan's words, and it was replaced by a cold expression.

"You're going to challenge the Stairway to Heaven soon, right? I have no doubt that you will be able to pass the trials and reach the Third Heaven with your talents, but once you ascend, you will not be able to return without my Ji Family's permission."

"Once you are gone, who will protect your friends? Who will be able to stop me— or anyone from harming your friends?" Lord Ji narrowed his eyes at Yuan.

Although Yuan isn't aware of it, Lord Ji was only bluffing. As the Lord of Spirit Heaven, he cannot act against the residences of the world he governs without a proper reason, or he will be punished by the Heavens and have his authority stripped.

This means that even if he hates someone with all of his guts, he cannot harm that individual unless that person does something that violates the laws of this world and blatantly goes against the Heavens.

With that being said, that doesn't restrict Patriarch Gu and his family from harming Wang Xiuying and the others once Yuan leaves this world, so that is a possibility.

"So what you're saying is that I should remove the Ji Family and the Gu Family from this world before I ascend to the next world, right? As much as I hate killing, if it means my friends are safe..." Yuan suddenly released his cultivation base.

'What a terrifying aura! Even though he's only a Spirit Lord, he emits a pressure that surpasses even mine as a peak Spirit King!' Lord Ji was shocked inwardly by Yuan's talents.

The source of this content is [f r e e w e b n o v e l . c o m]

Yuan's aura was so powerful that it choked Patriarch Gu, who was a Spirit King.

"Calm down, Yuan. I won't fight you. In fact, I cannot harm you until you attack me." Lord Ji raised his hand to surrender.

"If you really want to kill these two behind me, I won't stop you."

"What?! Lord Ji! You cannot abandon them after giving us hope! It's too cruel!" Patriarch Gu was shocked to hear such words.

"Please, Lord Ji! Save us!" Disciple Gu cried out loud.

Lord Ji looked at Patriarch Gu and said, "You know that I cannot physically intervene in your conflicts. I have already done everything that I could. I thought that words would be enough to stop this young man, but I was wrong. He's more crazy than I thought— crazy enough to threaten my Ji Family."

He then faced Yuan and continued, "I admire your attitude and boldness, Yuan. However, you have caused me to lose face before so many influential people today, and nobody that goes against me or my Ji Family has ever gotten away unpunished."

"It might not happen tomorrow or a month later, but mark my words, I will not forget this slap in my face, Yuan."

Despite showing no signs of anger, his voice was so cold that it caused everyone there but Yuan to tremble in fear.

"This is your last chance. Choose wisely." Lord Ji suddenly moved away from Elder Gu and Gu Zhiting, giving Yuan a clear path to them.

Yuan narrowed his eyes on Lord Ji, wondering if it was a trap. However, Lord Ji showed no signs of wanting to interfere.

"Please! Spare us! We were wrong! I swear that I won't harm you or your friends in the future!" Elder Gu pleaded.

"M-Me too! I swear that I—"

However, before Gu Zhiting could even finish his sentence, Yuan mercilessly swung his sword, killing the both of them with his Sword Aura almost instantly.

"BROTHER! SON! NO!!!" Patriarch Gu roared in despair.

Lord Ji took a deep breath after witnessing Elder Gu and Gu Zhiting's death, and he turned to look at Yuan with a vicious face, who was looking at the Grail of Truth, which was emitting a golden glow.

"I would have spared them if this treasure didn't have a reaction. Unfortunately..." Yuan sighed in a low voice.

Chapter 929 - Heavens' Judgment

Chapter 929 - Heavens' Judgment

"This crazy bastard..." Lord Ji mumbled in a low voice as he watched Elder Gu and Gu Zhiting's severed corpses fall to the ground from the sky.

'Is this what it feels like to be opposed? How interesting...' He smiled inwardly.

"He really killed them..." Wang Xiuying was left speechless by Yuan's actions. She didn't think he would actually kill them.

Sometime later, Yuan turned to look at Patriarch Gu and spoke in a calm voice, "Are you going to avenge them now? Will you also plot to harm my friends once I am gone?"

"..."

However, Patriarch Gu remained silent.

The Grail of Truth had a single weakness. If someone doesn't speak, it would not be able to detect any lies. However, by avoiding the Grail of Truth, they might as well be a liar. After all, there would be no point to avoid the Grail of Truth if one planned on speaking the truth.

"If you don't answer my question, I will kill you as well." Yuan narrowed his eyes at Patriarch Gu, who trembled upon feeling such gaze.

After a moment of silence, he spoke in a low voice, "Kill me if you want. I don't care anymore."

He then turned to look at Lord Ji and clasped his hands before continuing, "Thank you for responding to my request for help. Even if you were not able to save their lives, I am still grateful that you came, and I am indebted to you."

Lord Ji silently nodded.

Patriarch Gu turned to look at Yuan again for a moment before turning around and flying away.

Yuan narrowed his eyes at Patriarch Gu, but he didn't chase after him.

"Young Master, are you sure you want to let him go? My experience tells me that he will definitely try to avenge his son and brother in the future." Feng Yuxiang said to him.

"I know." Yuan said.

"Then why?"

"His eyes lacked any will to live, and it reminds me of someone. I cannot kill him even if I want to— my body doesn't allow it." He sighed.

The current Patriarch Gu reminded Yuan of himself during his early years as a cripple. He had no reason to live, and he couldn't care less if he lived or died. This made him hesitant on killing Patriarch Gu.

"However, that doesn't mean I will allow him to harm my friends. They all believe that I won't be able to return to this place once I ascend, but that is not even close to being true. If he dares to try anything funny, I will come back down here and finish them off."

"What about this Lord Ji? His Ji Family is incredibly powerful— even more powerful than the Seven Legacy Families. They will definitely try to suppress you, but I highly discourage you from fighting them. Although you might be able to defeat them now, you won't be able to deal with the Ji Family in the upper heavens." Feng Yuxiang asked.

"I don't know. This Lord Ji is a weird one. I do not understand him at all."
Yuan shook his head inwardly.

And he continued, "I guess we can only wait and see how everything goes."

Once Patriarch Gu left the scene completely, Lord Ji spoke in a calm voice, "You're really one crazy bastard, Yuan. Nobody has ever opposed me this openly. I'm both impressed and filled with rage right now."

"What do you think I should do with you, hmm?"

Yuan smiled and responded in a calm voice, "You can forget about this incident. This is the best for both of us. Furthermore, you're not even supposed to be here in the first place."

Lord Ji shook his head and spoke, "Unfortunately, that is no longer possible. You have opposed me, causing me to lose a lot of face today. Personally, I am not one who cares too much about face, but the Heavens watching us might think differently."

"If I don't punish you for opposing me, the Heavens that have witnessed everything might deem me unworthy of the position of Lord and strip my status, and that is something I cannot allow even if it costs me my life."

"The Heavens?" Yuan raised his eyebrows and lifted his head to look up.

"They're watching us now?"

Lord Ji smiled, "The Heavens are always watching us— all of us."

'Is that any different from the saying that God is always watching us?' Yuan wondered to himself.

"So what are you going to do now? Are you going to fight me and reclaim your face?" Yuan asked a moment later.

"No, I won't fight you. Violence isn't always the answer, and the Ji Family has their own methods to deal with you."

"However, let's see what the Heavens have to say about this."

Lord Ji suddenly retrieved a clear double terminated crystal and raised it above him.

"Judgment!" He shouted a moment later.

A sea of white clouds began gathering above their location, but the clouds started turning darker in color as time passed.

Within moments, the once white clouds were pitch black.

BANG!

A single lightning strike suddenly descended from the black clouds and struck the crystal in Lord Ji's grasp.

The clear crystal began changing colors shortly after, and within moments, it became just like the clouds— pitch black.

"T-This is..." Lord Ji appeared to be shocked and terrified at the same time when he saw the results.

He stared at the black crystal with wide eyes as the clouds began to disperse.

'Feng Feng, I have a bad feeling about this. Do you know what he's doing?' Yuan asked her.

"The Lords have the ability to call upon the Heavens for judgment of certain individuals. This is my first time witnessing it personally, but I have heard rumors. If the crystal turns golden, it means the Heavens are willing to forgive that person. The crystal can also turn red, but that means punishment for the person it judged."

"However, I have never heard of a pitch black crystal before." Feng Yuxiang said in a puzzled voice.

"Is that so..." Yuan mumbled, and they all patiently waited for Lord Ji to announce the results of his judgment.

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Chapter 930 - Tier 4 Body Tempering Pill

Chapter 930 - Tier 4 Body Tempering Pill

Many moments passed since Lord Ji's crystal turned pitch black, but he hasn't uttered a single word since then.

Yuan could no longer wait and asked him, "Hey, what's the Heavens' judgment? Judging by the ominous color, it can't be anything good, right?"

Lord Ji finally snapped out of his daze and turned to face Yuan with a profound frown on his face.

And without explaining anything, he turned around and flew away.

"What the heck? He's running away?" Yuan was dumbfounded by the Lord's action.

"Hey! Where are you going?! Come back here and explain the situation!"

He thought about chasing after Lord Ji, but he decided to let him go for now.

"What was that all about?" Wang Xiuying approached him afterward and asked.

"I have no idea." Yuan shrugged.

"Anyways, are you hurt?" He asked her.

"I should be asking you that question."

"I'm fine." Yuan smiled.

"I apologize... If I didn't leave the sect, none of this would've happened." Sect Master Xiahou apologized to him again.

"Don't kick yourself. It's not your fault." Yuan shook his head,

"By the way, what are you guys doing here?" Yuan turned to look at the other Sect Masters.

"We were in a meeting when you interrupted us... again." Sect Master Li said.

"After hearing about the situation from Sect Master Xiahou, we decided to tag along just in case." Bai Enjue said.

"Just in case what? That I decided to destroy this place? Do I look like a villain to you? I am a reasonable person. I won't harm innocent people." Yuan laughed out loud.

"Anyways, let's go back. I want to soak in some hot water after all that. Luckily, I have a cauldron and some pills that I want to test out."

While Yuan and Wang Xiuying returned to the sect, Sect Master Xiahou called for disciples to clean up the mess caused by the incident.

Elder Gu and Gu Zhiting's corpses were gathered, stitched up, and sent back to the Gu Family.

As for the collapsed cave, the Sect Master decided to completely demolish it.

The other Sect Masters returned to their own sect shortly after.

"My god, Yuan. It hasn't even been a full day since you arrived and you've already caused so much chaos." Wang Xiuying said to him after they returned to her living quarters.

"You're blaming me? I am the victim here!" He exclaimed.

"I know, it's just a joke. By the way, are you really going to temper yourself with the Tier 4 and Tier 5 Body Tempering Pills? I really think you should hold off on them for now."

Yuan smiled, "Have some faith in me."

"Anyways, how do I use this thing?" He showed her the cauldron he just got.

"You need to form a connection with it first. Drop some of your blood on it and establish a connection with your spiritual sense. After that, you will be able to change its size with a thought."

Yuan nodded and dropped some of his blood onto the cauldron.

After he injected some of his spiritual energy into the cauldron, he could immediately feel a connection to it, almost like his connections with his servants.

Once the connection was strong enough, Yuan could change the cauldron's size with a mere thought, and it felt extremely natural, almost as though he'd been doing it for years.

"Wow, this is big enough to fit four people!" Yuan was pleasantly surprised by the cauldron's maximum size.

"Now you fill the cauldron up with water and heat it up using a flame technique. If you don't have any fire-making techniques, I can help you." Wang Xiuying said.

"Actually, I might have one. However, I have never used it."

Yuan proceeded to activate a technique that he'd learned early on but never got the chance to use—

[Heavenly Fire Control]

A ball of flame appeared on Yuan's palms.

"What do you think? It's a Mortal-rank technique meant for cooking." Yuan said with a smile on his face.

Wang Xiuying rubbed her temples and sighed, "You won't be able to warm the cauldron with such a pitifully weak fire, much less warm the water..."

"I-Is that so...Well, its description does say 'regular' fire." Yuan shrugged.

"Don't worry, I will help you heat up the—"

However, before Wang Xiuying could even finish her sentence, Feng Yuxiang appeared beside Yuan and used her phoenix fire to heat up the cauldron almost instantly.

"Y-You are..." Wang Xiuying stared at Feng Yuxiang's pretty face for a moment before turning to admire her beautiful golden flames.

"Wow... What pretty and powerful flames. This must be named Alchemy Flame!"

"Huh? Alchemy Flame? How dare you compare my Phoenix fire to Alchemy Flames! My flames are much more special than any Alchemy Flame out there!" Feng Yuxiang said in a bragging tone.

"Huh? Phoenix fire? I have never heard of such a thing before," said Wang Xiuying in a dazed voice.

"I'm not surprised." Feng Yuxiang sneered.

Yuan smiled and said, "Feng Feng is a Divine Beast— a Phoenix."

"Wow, a phoenix? First dragons, now a phoenix? I always meet these mythical beings whenever I am with you, Yuan." Wang Xiuying smiled.

Sometime later, Yuan tossed the Tier 4 Body Tempering Pill into the boiling hot water and watched it disappear almost instantly, turning the clear water into a murky green color.

Yuan waited for a few more moments just to be safe before removing his clothes and entering the cauldron.

"I-I should wait outside..." Wang Xiuying said with a flushed face after seeing Yuan's naked body.

"You can stay. I don't mind." Yuan said to her as he sat down.

After taking a deep breath, he started absorbing the medicine, officially starting his body tempering.

Yuan immediately gritted his teeth when he sensed pain, but it wasn't unbearable.

In fact, it was nowhere near as painful as his first experience and when he tempered his body with Chu Liuxiang with the dragon scales.

"How do you feel, Yuan? You don't have to force yourself..." Wang Xiuying said to him in a nervous voice.

"I'm fine. This much pain is very bearable," he calmly said.

"No way..." She mumbled with a dumbfounded look on her face.

Chapter 931 - Becoming an Alchemist

Chapter 931 - Becoming an Alchemist

"Since you're able to endure the pain and nothing seems to be wrong, I will leave you alone and go concoct some pills. How long will you be staying there? A single pill can last you a week even if you are soaked in it the entire time." Wang Xiuying asked him.

"I'll temper my body for a few hours. It would be a waste of money if I leave so quickly," he said.

"Okay. Have fun." Wang Xiuying went to her room to concoct pills.

Three hours later, Yuan opened his eyes and looked at the clear water with raised eyebrows,

"I thought she said that it'd last a week. It's only been three hours since I started and the medicine is already all gone." Yuan mumbled in a low voice.

"Young Master, did you already forget? You have a special body and incredible talents. It's only natural that you'd absorb the medicine much quicker than others." Feng Yuxiang said.

"I'm well aware of that, but when it takes only a few short hours to absorb a week's worth of medicine... At this rate, I will need to buy a lot of Body Tempering Pills. I don't even dare to imagine how much money it will cost me if I want to temper my body for 1 month." Yuan sighed.

"The most efficient way to save money on pills is to concoct them yourself. Although the ingredients are costly as well, you can easily make a profit

with a single decent pill. If you concoct two pills and sell one of them you'll gain enough money to buy ingredients to concoct another two or three pills, even more if the pill is of high quality." Feng Yuxiang said.

Yuan sighed, "So you're telling me to become an Alchemist and concoct the pills myself? I wanted to be an Alchemist at one point, but after learning the process, I gave up on that thought."

"No offense to Xiuying and all of the Alchemists out there, but I just find it way too boring. Honestly, if I wasn't able to consume monster cores and raise my cultivation that way, I would've hated cultivation."

Feng Yuxiang began pondering after hearing Yuan's words.

"I have a suggestion," she said a moment later, and she continued, "If the Young Master refuses to do Alchemy, why don't I concoct pills for you?"

"Huh?" Yuan looked at her with wide eyes.

"You want to concoct pills for me? Do you know how to concoct pills?"

She shook her head, "No, I have never concocted a pill before, nor do I have any experience in Alchemy."

"Then how are you going to concoct pills? I can't ask you to learn Alchemy just to help me save money. That's too much." Yuan rejected her idea.

Feng Yuxiang then said, "Actually, even if I don't have any experience, I am very confident in my abilities to concoct pills. After all, a large part of Alchemy is basically how well one can control their flames."

"I may be a young phoenix, but I am very confident in my mastery over my own flames. Furthermore, my phoenix flame can rival even the best Alchemy Flames out there. I meet pretty much every necessary requisite for an Alchemist— a powerful fire, perfect control over that fire, and I also have extensive knowledge on medicine and herbs because of my previous occupation. If you ask me, I am essentially an Alchemist already."

Yuan stared at her with a look of disbelief, and he mumbled in a low voice, "If you put it that way..."

"Now I just need to successfully concoct a pill. Once that is done, I can call myself an Alchemist and start concocting pills for you! I will be right back, Young Master! You can go ahead and try out the Tier 5 Body Tempering Pill."

"Where are you going?" He asked out of curiosity.

"I'm going to borrow your friend's cauldron and try to concoct a pill!"

After saying that, Feng Yuxiang left the room and went to find Wang Xiuying, who was practicing Tier 4 pills in her own room.

"71 percent purity... Haaaa... It'll probably take me another month before I can concoct Tier 4 pills with over 90 percent purity..." Wang Xiuying sighed.

Despite already having the ability to concoct Tier 4 pills without failing 10 out of 10 times, she won't consider it a success until she can concoct a Tier 4 pill with over 90 percent purity.

In fact, she refuses to touch Tier 5 pills until she can 'successfully' concoct a Tier 4 pill. This stubbornness has caused her Master plenty of headaches.

"Alright! Let's try again!"

However, Feng Yuxiang knocked on her door right as she stood up to gather more ingredients.

"Hm? Did something happen to Yuan?" Wang Xiuying asked after seeing Feng Yuxiang standing outside her room.

"No, I came here because I have a request. Can you concoct a Body Tempering Pill for me? I also want to watch you make it."

"I don't mind, but can I ask why? Yuan is already using Tier 4 Body Tempering Pills while I can only concoct Tier 3 Body Tempering Pills."

"I want to see if I can concoct a pill." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Eh?" Wang Xiuying raised her eyebrows in a questioning manner.

"Are you an Alchemist as well? I mean, you do have a very powerful fire..."

"No, I am not... yet."

"I-Is that so... I guess I can concoct a Tier 3 Body Tempering Pill for you." Wang Xiuying accepted her request.

"Thank you."

While Wang Xiuying gathered the ingredients, Feng Yuxiang took a seat in front of the cauldron right beside where Wang Xiuying will be seated.

Once Wang Xiuying was seated and began concocting the pill, Feng Yuxiang paid close attention to her Alchemy Flame.

From the temperature of Wang Xiuying's Alchemy Flame to the way she adjusted its intensity— Feng Yuxiang memorized all of it with a single glance.

Chapter 932 - Feng Yuxiang's Alchemy

Chapter 932 - Feng Yuxiang's Alchemy

While Feng Yuxiang went to watch Wang Xiuying concoct pills, Yuan tested out the Tier 5 Body Tempering Pill.

"Shit! This is painful!" He exclaimed in a shocked voice after trying to absorb the medicine.

"I didn't think the difference between Tier 4 and Tier 5 would be this vast. This pain is comparable to my first experience."

However, despite the pain, Yuan felt relieved. After all, if the Tier 5 Body Tempering Pills were not strong enough, he would need to use Tier 6 Body Tempering Pills, and who knows how much a single one of those would cost.

An hour later, Wang Xiuying retrieved the Tier 3 Body Tempering Pill that she'd just concocted from the cauldron.

"How was that?" She asked.

"I have memorized everything. Thank you. Now I would like to try." Feng Yuxiang said.

"You want to try? You know... I don't want to sound arrogant, but if concocting pills were this easy, everyone would be an Alchemist."

"Maybe not human cultivators. However, in case you forgot, I am not human. I am a phoenix with fire mastery that most humans cannot even

begin to comprehend."

Feng Yuxiang stood up and asked, "Can I use your medicines for my pill?"

"Sure... Use as many as you want." Wang Xiuying nodded.

After gathering enough ingredients to concoct three Tier 3 Body Tempering Pills, Feng Yuxiang returned to the cauldron.

"If I cannot successfully concoct a pill with three attempts, I will admit defeat and learn Alchemy from the beginning."

Feng Yuxiang proceeded to summon her phoenix fire around the cauldron, and Wang Xiuying stared with wide eyes.

'Her control over the flames is immaculate... She's even better than my Master...' Wang Xiuying was shocked inwardly by Feng Yuxiang's performance even though she hadn't even begun putting the ingredients inside.

Sometime later, Feng Yuxiang tossed the first ingredient into the cauldron and adjusted the strength of her flames so that it wouldn't burn the ingredient.

'My god, she melted the ingredient almost instantly and even destroyed all of the impurities at the same time. I have never seen anything like this before...' Wang Xiuying exclaimed inwardly as she watched Feng Yuxiang toss ingredients into the cauldron every five seconds.

The speed of Feng Yuxiang's Alchemy was truly shocking for someone like Wang Xiuying, as it was many times faster than even her Master, who was the best Alchemist in the Spirit Heaven.

Feng Yuxiang melted all of the ingredients needed to concoct the pill within minutes, and after another minute, she finished concocting the Tier 3 Body Tempering Pill.

"Looks pretty good to me. What do you think?" Feng Yuxiang handed the pill to Wang Xiuying after glancing at it.

[Body Tempering Pill] [Tier: 3] [Purity: 99%]

[Effects: Used for body tempering. Toss in water and wait until the pill completely dissolves. Only recommended for Spirit Grandmasters and above.]

[Description: Concocted by Feng Yuxiang] [*Updated from F r e e w e b n o v e l . c o m*]

"Unbelievable... You really concocted a Tier 3 Body Tempering Pill on your first try... And it even has a 99 percent purity! Please tell me you were only joking with me when you said that you had no experience with Alchemy!" Wang Xiuying looked at Feng Yuxiang with teary eyes.

"This is really my first time doing Alchemy." Feng Yuxiang calmly shrugged.

And to Feng Yuxiang's surprise, Wang Xiuying suddenly began crying, "If Yuan has someone as talented as you by his side, there's no longer any reason for someone like me to exist! All of my efforts would be in vain! And Alchemy is the only thing that I am good with in this world! Why am I so unlucky?! I only wanted to be helpful to him!"

Feng Yuxiang was completely baffled by Wang Xiuying's sudden outburst. She didn't think that she would upset Wang Xiuying this much by concocting a single pill.

"I'm sorry, but I don't really understand..." Feng Yuxiang said a few moments later.

Wang Xiuying wiped her tears and said, "Yuan is a very talented person, some may even say that he's too talented. He's also someone that I idolize very much, so I want to help him in any way that I can. However, since he's very talented, there are very few things that I can help him with."

"The field of medicine is one of these very few things that Yuan has zero experience and interest in, so I came to this place to study Alchemy. I wanted to help Yuan with the pills that I'd concocted. However, now that

you're in the picture, I will no longer need to concoct any pills for him since you'll definitely do much better than me. Do you understand my frustration now?"

Feng Yuxianbg nodded in a dazed manner.

"Believe it or not, I actually understand your feelings very well. I also want to help him, but besides offering him treasures and some of my knowledge, there's really not much that I can do to assist him, and he will eventually acquire more treasures and knowledge than me."

"However, he just told me that he's reluctant to learn Alchemy since he finds it very boring, and that's when I got the idea of becoming an Alchemist. This way, I will be able to stand by his side and not feel useless even in the future when he's standing at the peak of this world."

"I see... If that's the case, then I don't mind giving up on Alchemy. As a nurse, I only want what's best for my patients, and you're clearly the best out there— at least way better than me." Wang Xiuying sighed.

"What? You're going to give up Alchemy because of this? That's nonsense!" Feng Yuxiang said.

"I mean... I only started Alchemy so that I could help him... Is there a point for me to continue if I cannot help him?"

"Of course! Don't you enjoy concocting pills? You even said it yourself that you do! I will take care of the Young Master in your place, so you should start concocting pills for yourself." Feng Yuxiang said,

And she continued, "Furthermore, the Young Master will be leaving this world soon. Unless you plan on ascending with him, you won't be able to help him with your Alchemy."

"What?! Yuan is leaving this world already?! He just got here!" Wang Xiuying exclaimed after learning this information for the first time.

Chapter 933 - Violet Qilin's Fire

Chapter 933 - Violet Qilin's Fire

"W-When is he leaving?!" Wang Xiuying asked afterward.

"Soon. Probably after he finishes visiting this place." Feng Yuxiang said.

"What?! That's less than a week!"

"Yes... That's why I don't recommend you quit being an Alchemist. Unless you ascend with him, you won't be able to help him. After all, it's not like he can come down here every time he needs some pills from you."

"Furthermore, you're very talented in Alchemy. It would be a waste of talent if you stop now."

Wang Xiuying sighed, "I guess so..."

"You know, as a phoenix, I was born with the talent to control flames, and I have over 100,000 years of experience. You, on the other hand, are a human with less than 20 years of experience. If you continue being an Alchemist, I have no doubt you'll eventually surpass me in the future."

Wang Xiuying nodded with a serious expression on her face, "Then I will continue to practice Alchemy with a new goal in mind— to surpass you and stand by Yuan's side as his number one Alchemist in the future."

Feng Yuxiang smiled and said, "And I will start studying Alchemy seriously so that I can continue being his Alchemist. I won't go easy on you."

"I would never ask you to go easy on me, or that would make this entire thing meaningless. After all, we both want the best for Yuan."

Feng Yuxiang nodded, "Now then, if I want to study Alchemy, I will need some manuals. Does the Alchemy Store sell them?"

"Yes, they do, but they will only sell them to disciples of the sect. If you want some manuals, you can take mine. I no longer have any use for them since I've already memorized everything." Wang Xiuying retrieved over 20 manuals and scrolls on Alchemy and medicine, placing them before Feng Yuxiang.

Feng Yuxiang smiled and said, "In exchange for your manuals, I will give you some treasures. What do you want? Weapons? Rare ingredients?"

"It's okay, I don't need any payment. These manuals aren't that expensive, either. They cost less than 1,000 gold coins together."

"I don't like owing debt to anyone. Even if they're worth one gold coin, I will pay for it." Feng Yuxiang shook her head.

She started searching inside her spatial ring the very next moment.

A few moments later, Feng Yuxiang retrieved a pill-sized clear marble that contained purple flames.

"I will give you this for the manuals." Feng Yuxiang handed this fiery marble to Wang Xiuying.

"What's this?" Wang Xiuying asked as she accepted the marble.

"This marble contains fire from a Violet Qilin, a powerful and rare magical beast known for their natural fire mastery. If you consume this treasure, you will gain the magical beast's talent, which will greatly boost your control of most flames out there, including Alchemy Flames."

"Wow... Are you sure you want to give me this treasure? It looks and sounds very expensive. How much would a treasure like this cost?" Wang Xiuying asked out of curiosity.

"Somewhere between 50 to 60 million spirit stones, I guess."

"F-Fifty million spirit stones?!" Wang Xiuying exclaimed in a shocked voice.

"This treasure is way too valuable! My manuals are only worth 1,000 gold coins at most!"

Feng Yuxiang shrugged and said, "Consider this as an investment."

"An investment? For what?" Wang Xiuying raised her eyebrows in a questioning manner.

Feng Yuxiang smiled and said, "While I don't like owing debts, I love it when people owe me."

"In the future, if I need something from you, just remember this debt you owe me. That's all."

"That sounds very suspicious. Like a loan shark. You won't ask me to do something ridiculous, right?" Wang Xiuying said in a doubtful voice.

"Who knows."

Wang Xiuying swallowed nervously. However, despite such a suspicious deal, she could not refuse the Violet Qilin's fire.

'Since she is Yuan's friend, I can trust her... probably. And this treasure is just too good. I will definitely regret it for a very long time if I don't accept it.'

After pondering for a moment, Wang Xiuying gave up and said, "Fine, I owe you."

"Anyways, how do I use this treasure? Do I just swallow it?"

Feng Yuxiang nodded, "Yes, swallow the entire thing. If you break the marble, the fire will explode and kill you."

"T-That's incredibly dangerous! What if it explodes after I swallow it?!"

"Don't worry, the marble won't break that easily, and once it's in your stomach, it will slowly release the Violet Qilin's fire, but you will see results immediately. Also, your stomach will feel like it's on fire for the next few days, but it won't hurt you. Once you absorb all of the Violet Qilin's fire, your control with fire will significantly improve, almost as though you'd suddenly gained 1,000 years of experience."

"I understand. Thank you for the explanation and for this treasure." Wang Xiuying gently placed the marble in her mouth and swallowed it.

She could immediately feel her stomach's temperature increasing, and it was actually quite comfortable.

A few moments later, Wang Xiuying could no longer resist her curiosity and started playing around with her Alchemy Flame, and to her absolute shock, she could immediately see improvements just like Feng Yuxiang said.

"This is amazing! I can't believe how much I have improved already!" Wang Xiuying was jumping in joy as she danced around the room with her Alchemy Flames.

"If you're already this impressed, just wait until you finish absorbing the treasure." Feng Yuxiang said.

And she continued, "Of course, you will need way more than this treasure to beat me."

"Thank you! I will definitely repay this debt!" Wang Xiuying suddenly approached Feng Yuxiang and embraced her tightly.

"H-Hey! Who said you can hug me?! Only the Young Master is allowed to be intimate with my body!" Feng Yuxiang quickly pushed her away.

Wang Xiuying didn't mind being pushed away and even laughed.

"What a weird girl..." Feng Yuxiang shook her head inwardly.

Chapter 934 - Drastic Improvements

Chapter 934 - Drastic Improvements

Once she calmed down, Wang Xiuying tried to concoct pills to see the results of the treasure.

"I-I did it! Tier 4 pill with 90 percent purity! And I thought I would need another month before I can reach this point!" Wang Xiuying kissed the pill in her hands with teary eyes.

"..." Feng Yuxiang watched with a pondering look on her face.

'Her improvements are insane even considering that she'd consumed Violet Qilin's fire. She's simply improving too fast. Maybe she has a unique physique that's causing this?'

It's only been an hour since Wang Xiuying consumed the treasure, but she's already able to improve her Tier 4 pills from 70 percent to 90 percent purity. This kind of improvement would normally need a day, but she was able to achieve such results in only an hour.

"Hey, what kind of Physique do you have?" Feng Yuxiang decided to ask her.

"Me? I have a Physique called Pure Flame Physique."

"Pure Flame Physique, huh? That explains your tremendous improvements." Feng Yuxiang mumbled.

"Do you know what my physique is? Even my Master doesn't know about it." Wang Xiuying said.

Feng Yuxiang nodded and said, "The Pure Flame Physique allows you to consume many different types of flames to improve your own cultivation, and the flames you absorb will also have strengthened results, meaning you acquire more benefits than what's normally gained."

"I must say, it's one of the best physiques out there for Alchemists. You got really lucky."

"I see... Wait, what kind of fire can I consume, specifically?" Wang Xiuying then asked.

"You can consume most flames out there, including Alchemy Flames."

"Eh? Won't that be a waste? Consuming Alchemy Flames."

"No, it won't be wasted, since you'll be able to use all the flames you consume."

"Really?! Does that mean I can also use the Violet Qilin's purple flames?!" Wang Xiuying asked in an excited voice.

"Let's not get ahead of ourselves. You'll still need enough cultivation to use the flames. If you want to use the Violet Qilin's purple flames, you will need to be at least a Spirit Emperor."

"S-Spirit Emperor? How high is that?"

"Above Spirit King."

"Spirit King?! That's my Master's cultivation! It will take years for me to reach that kind of level, not even mentioning Spirit Emperor!" Wang Xiuying exclaimed.

"There's nothing I can do about that. The Violet Qilin is a powerful magical beast found in the Fourth Heaven and above, so it's only natural that you need a high cultivation base to use it."

Wang Xiuying sighed, "Guess I will have to give up on this matter for now..."

Sometime later, Wang Xiuying continued to concoct Tier 4 pills until she could concoct above 90 percent purity 10 out of 10 times.

When the sky started turning dark, Yuan finished his body tempering and went to meet with the other two.

"How did it go, Feng Feng? Were you able to concoct a pill?" Yuan asked her.

"Take a look at this!" Feng Yuxiang showed him the Tier 3 Body Tempering Pill that she'd concocted.

"Wow, you actually did it? That's amazing. Sorry I doubted you."

"Don't worry about it. Now we will be able to save a lot of money on pills, and you will essentially have an endless source of Body Tempering Pills!"

Yuan nodded, "How long do you think it will take you to be able to concoct Tier 5 Body Tempering Pills?"

"I can't say right now, but it shouldn't take too long, considering how easy I was able to concoct a Tier 3 pill."

"Alright, I will leave it to you."

"Anyways, I will see you tomorrow, Xiuying. Our tour was cut short today, but we can resume it tomorrow." Yuan said to her.

"Sure thing."

"Young Master, can I borrow your cauldron for now? I want to start practicing Alchemy immediately." Feng Yuxiang suddenly asked him.

"Of course. I left it in the other room."

"Thank you."

Yuan logged off the game shortly after. Wang Xiuying continued to concoct pills for another hour before leaving too. As for Feng Yuxiang, she would spend the rest of the night practicing her Alchemy.

The following day, when Yuan returned to Cultivation Online, Feng Yuxiang greeted him with a wide smile on her face.

"What's up, Feng Feng? Did something good happen?" He asked her.

"Look at this!"

Feng Yuxiang showed him the pill in her hands.

[Body Tempering Pill] [Tier: 4] [Purity: 94%]

[Effects: Used for body tempering. Toss in water and wait until the pill completely dissolves. Only recommended for Spirit Grandmasters and above.]

[Description: Concocted by Feng Yuxiang]

"Tier 4 Body Tempering Pill? You can already concoct Tier 4 pills?" Yuan was surprised by her ridiculous improvement speed.

At this rate, she will be able to concoct Tier 5 pills by tomorrow!

"I wanted to try concocting a Tier 5 Body Tempering Pill, but even your friend doesn't have the recipe for it."

"I see... Let's try asking Sect Master Xiahou for it later."

"Okay."

Wang Xiuying logged on about an hour later.

"I wanted to watch the competition with you today, but because of what happened yesterday, it was canceled. Disciple Gu was a competitor, after all."

"Then let's do something else." Yuan said.

She nodded, "We can continue where we left off yesterday."

"Sure."

They made their way to the Alchemy Store shortly after.

Once they arrived, Wang Xiuying started showing Yuan around the rest of the sect.

"This is where lectures are given. Elders will show up once a week and concoct pills before the disciples."

"This is the study hall, where we memorize all sorts of medicine out there with our eyes and nose."

"This is where disciples with no money can go to practice their Alchemy. Outer Court disciples have access to the normal cauldrons while Inner Court disciples have access to enhanced cauldrons."

After showing Yuan almost everything there is to see, Wang Xiuying asked him, "What do you want to do now?"

"Hmmm... Do you think we can see your Master now? I want to see if we can buy the recipe for the Tier 5 Body Tempering Pill."

"Then let's go to her headquarters and see if she's there."

"Okay." Yuan nodded.

Chapter 935 - Number One Servant

Chapter 935 - Number One Servant

Upon Yuan's request, Wang Xiuying brought him to the Sect Master's headquarters.

"Master, are you inside?" Wang Xiuying knocked on her door.

As Sect Master Xiahou's disciple, Wang Xiuying had access to the building, so she could enter and leave as she pleased, something even a lot of Sect Elders couldn't do.

"Yes, I am here." Sect Master Xiahou's voice quickly resounded.

After all, she couldn't risk accidentally offending Yuan again, so she decided to stay in the sect until he leaves.

"Yuan would like to speak with you."

"Y-Yuan?! C-Come inside!"

The nervousness within Sect Master Xiahou's voice was apparent, causing Wang Xiuying to show a bittersweet smile as she opened the door and entered the room with Yuan.

"Hello, Sect Master." Yuan greeted her with a gentle smile.

"W-What do you want?"

However, in Sect Master Xiahou's eyes, his smile was very terrifying. After all, Yuan had the audacity to go against the Ji Family that ruled almost half of the Nine Heavens.

"I'd like to purchase the Tier 5 Body Tempering Pill from your sect." Yuan did not beat around the bush and said.

"Why do you need something like that? Do you plan on concocting them yourself?" Sect Master Xiahou asked with a pondering look on her face.

"No, not me. My friend will be the one doing Alchemy. Feng Feng."

The red-haired beauty Feng Yuxiang appeared in the room beside Yuan the next moment.

"My name is Feng Yuxiang. I am the Young Master's most loyal and number one servant." Feng Yuxiang introduced herself.

However, before Sect Master Xiahou could even respond, another figure appeared in the room— a petite figure with a cute face.

"Xiao Hua will not let such comments slide, you sly bird! Xiao Hua came first, so she is Brother Yuan's number one servant."

Feng Yuxiang rubbed her nose in a cheeky manner and said, "Oh yeah? While you may have been his first servant, I am definitely in the lead when it comes to helping him! And very soon, I will help the Young Master even more with my Alchemy!"

Xiao Hua gritted her teeth in frustration, but she was unable to refute Feng Yuxiang's words. It was true that Feng Yuxiang has been very helpful to Yuan as of late. Not only has she helped him save and earn a lot of money, but she even has what seems like an endless supply of valuable treasures for him. Now that she'll also be concocting pills for Yuan, Feng Yuxiang's status as his servant has risen to a new level!

At glance, Feng Yuxiang is definitely in the lead out of the three of them!

"X-Xiao Hua can also be useful to Brother Yuan!" Xiao Hua said, and she started taking out powerful weapons and artifacts that emitted the aura of Divine-grade and even Ancient-grade treasures.

Everyone in the room felt their jaw drop to the ground after seeing the amount of treasures in Xiao Hua's grasp.

"Here, Brother Yuan! Take these!" She offered them to him with a stubborn face.

Yuan could only shake his head with a smile, "Don't be silly. I never cared about who is more useful to me, nor will I ever rank you guys based on your usefulness. In my eyes, you're all my precious companions."

However, despite Yuan's words, Xiao Hua did not feel content. Because of her rivalry with Feng Yuxiang, she couldn't help but feel like she was losing — that she was inferior.

"Feng Feng, you should also stop thinking like that. It's an unhealthy mindset to have." Yuan scolded her next.

"S-Sorry..." She sighed with her head lowered.

They returned to his body shortly after.

Yuan sighed, and he spoke, "Anyways, I would like to purchase the Tier 5 Body Tempering Pill recipe from you. I know that recipes are very rare and extremely valuable, so I am going to offer you these..."

He retrieved a small wooden box and placed it before Sect Master Xiahou.

"T-This is... Is this what I think it is...?" Sect Master Xiahou asked in a trembling voice.

She had an idea of its contents even without looking inside, as she'd seen the wooden box before.

"Yes, it's leaves from the Golden Celestial Tree, and there are 9 crimson leaves inside the box. Oh, and before I forget, the Golden Celestial Tree

itself is a few million years old."

"What?! Leaves from a Golden Celestial Tree that is over a million years old?! How is that even possible?!" Sect Master Xiahou exclaimed.

"You can examine the leaves yourself if you do not believe me."

Sect Master Xiahou swallowed nervously.

"No, I trust you. I want to open it, but I don't dare to expose the leaves to any more impurities, so I will leave them inside the box."

'Nine blades of crimson leaves... I will be able to concoct three Golden Aptitude Pills! Even if I consume one for myself and give one to Xiuying, I will still have an extra! And these leaves came from a Golden Celestial Tree that is over a million years old! This is a treasure that I will never see again, much less acquire!' Sect Master Xiahou cried with joy inwardly.

"Judging by the smile on your face, I will assume that you are going to accept my trade?" Yuan suddenly said.

Unbeknownst to Sect Master Xiahou, there was a smile that was unbefitting of a woman on her face.

Upon realizing the expression on her, Sect Master Xiahou quickly covered her face and turned around as it was flushed with redness.

After a moment of silence, she spoke in a low voice, "Y-Yes, I accept this trade."

"Here is my medallion. Bring it to the Alchemy Store and show it to the people on the tenth floor. They will assist you with everything you need. In fact, you can ask for more pill recipes. These leaves are countless times more valuable than the Tier 5 Body Tempering Pill's recipe, after all."

Yuan accepted the medallion and bowed to her, "Thank you. You can take leaves now."

Yuan and Wang Xiuying left the place shortly after to head towards the Alchemy Store once again.

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Chapter 936 - Crazy Shopping Spree

Chapter 936 - Crazy Shopping Spree

Once they arrived at the Alchemy Store, Yuan and Wang Xiuying walked straight to the tenth floor.

However, they were blocked on the ninth floor.

"Only those that have received the Sect Master's approval may enter the tenth floor." The Elders said to them.

Yuan showed them Sect Master Xiahou's medallion.

"Please give us a minute to confirm it with the Sect Master." The Elder said.

The Elders took Yuan's medallion for a quick inspection while they also contacted Sect Master Xiahou to confirm that she had indeed handed her medallion to Yuan.

Once they confirmed everything, the Elders allowed them to enter the tenth floor.

The tenth floor was unsurprisingly the smallest but also the cleanest room in the entire building due to the minimal visitors they receive. In fact, visitors were practically nonexistent on the tenth floor, and only one or two people get to enter this place every year.

"How may I help you?" The Elder working on that floor asked them.

This Elder also happened to be a first level Spirit King and the guardian of the Alchemy Store.

"Hello, I'm here to buy the recipe for the Tier 5 Body Tempering Pill." Yuan said.

"Oh, I have already paid the Sect Master for the recipe, and she even allowed me to choose a couple more."

"I understand. Here is a list of all of the pill recipes we have in the sect." The Elder handed them a thin manual.

Yuan took the manual and asked Feng Yuxiang, "What do you think, Feng Feng? Any particular pill recipe you want beside the Tier 5 Body Tempering Pill?"

Feng Yuxiang appeared beside him and started looking through the manual.

'P-Peak Spirit King?!' The Elder was shocked by Feng Yuxiang's cultivation base and otherworldly beauty.

A few minutes later, Feng Yuxiang picked 21 different pill recipes, not including the Tier 5 Body Tempering Pill, and they were mostly recipes for Tier 5 pills.

The Elder's eyebrows twitched uncontrollably after seeing how many pill recipes Feng Yuxiang had chosen.

"W-Wait a moment while I receive the Sect Master's approval..." The Elder said to them before disappearing to the room in the back.

A few minutes later, the Elder returned with a look of disbelief on his face.

"T-The Sect Master has agreed to give you all of the pill recipes... You also don't need to worry about paying for them."

The Elder sounded like he was in disbelief, and he wondered what kind of bribe Yuan had given the Sect Master to make this happen. Normally, Sect

Master Xiahou would be very strict about giving away even one pill recipe, much less 22 at once.

After copying all of the pill recipes Feng Yuxiang had requested, the Elder handed it to her.

"Now we just need to buy enough ingredients to concoct the pills. The store still owes me 100,000 spirit stones, but I doubt that will be able to help much." Yuan said afterward.

"It's okay, Young Master. Leave everything pill-related to me, including the money." Feng Yuxiang suddenly said.

"Are you sure?"

"Yes. I won't lose any money as long as I successfully concoct one pill out of three attempts." She nodded.

"All right. I will leave it to you."

"I will also buy my own cauldron so I don't need to borrow yours every time I want to concoct pills." Feng Yuxiang added.

They descended to the sixth floor shortly after so that Feng Yuxiang could buy her cauldron.

"I want this Golden Phoenix Cauldron." Feng Yuxiang said to the Elder there.

"T-The Golden Phoenix Cauldron will cost 10 million spirit stones... It's also our best cauldron." The Elder said.

"Here." Feng Yuxiang handed him the money without any hesitation, almost as though she was only getting rid of her spare change.

"T-Thank you for your patronage!" All of the staff members there bowed to Feng Yuxiang after the purchase.

They descended to the third floor shortly after Feng Yuxiang got her own cauldron.

"I want enough medicine to concoct 1,000 Tier 5 Body Tempering Pills and..." Feng Yuxiang said to the staff members working there, shocking them speechless with her crazy shopping spree.

In the end, Feng Yuxiang left the Alchemy Store with a cauldron that cost her 10 million spirit stones and 5 million spirit stones' worth of ingredients.

It was an enormous sum of money spent. In fact, Feng Yuxiang instantly became their most valued customer.

"15 million spirit stones... I am speechless..." Wang Xiuying mumbled in a dazed voice.

"How just freaking rich are you?" She couldn't help but ask.

"I have sold tens of thousands of valuable treasures throughout thousands of years, so you can say that I have a decent amount of wealth. However, this much is nothing once we reach the upper heavens, where treasures will require Spirit Jades to purchase, which will be equivalent to billions and trillions of spirit stones."

"T-Trillions...?" Both Yuan and Wang Xiuying swallowed nervously.

Once they returned to Wang Xiuying's living quarters, Feng Yuxiang immediately holed herself in one of the guest rooms to practice her Alchemy.

"What do you want to do tomorrow, Yuan?" Wang Xiuying asked him when the sky started turning dark.

"I don't know. I wouldn't mind if we just relaxed and talked to each other about our adventures."

"That sounds great! Then I will see you tomorrow. Goodnight."

"Goodnight."

After Wang Xiuying logged off, Yuan prepared to log off.

However, Xiao Hua suddenly appeared before him and spoke in a low voice, "Brother Yuan, can you spend the night with Xiao Hua?"

"Huh?" He raised his eyebrows.

Xiao Hua then retrieved a familiar-looking book from her spatial ring and said, "Besides supplying Brother Yuan with weapons and artifacts, this is all that Xiao Hua can do for you..."

"Are you still worried about what Feng Feng said today? You really don't need to compare with each other."

"Please, Brother Yuan... Let Xiao Hua help you..." She said to him with moist eyes.

Yuan sighed, and he nodded with a gentle smile, "All right. I will spend the night with you and listen to you chant like old times."

Xiao Hua immediately nodded her small head with a bright smile.

The two of them went outside and sat in front of Wang Xiuying's medicine field.

Xiao Hua opened her book and started reading it while Yuan closed his eyes and focused on her voice.

Chapter 937 - Heaven Sealing Technique

Chapter 937 - Heaven Sealing Technique

After spending the entire night listening to Xiao Hua's voice, Yuan slowly opened his eyes right as the sunrise began.

<Your comprehension for Heaven's Secret Art has greatly increased>

<Heaven's Secret Art Mastery Level has been increased (3 → 4)>

<You have learned Heaven's Fourth Secret Art — Heaven Sealing Technique>

[Heaven Sealing Technique]

[Rank: Divine]

[Mastery Level: 1]

[Description: A heaven-defying technique that can seal one's meridians and cultivation. Limited to Spirit Kings and below(Can be increased through Mastery Level). Anyone within 10 meters of the user can be targeted(Can be increased through Mastery Level). Limited to 3 individuals at once(Can be increased through Mastery Level).]

<Heaven Consuming Technique Mastery Level has been increased (2 → 5)>

[Heaven Consuming Technique]

[Rank: Divine]

[Mastery Level: 5]

[Description: Absorbs 50,000,000 Qi per second.]

<Heaven Splitting Sword Strike Mastery Level has been increased (2 → 3)>

[Heaven Splitting Sword Strike]

[Rank: Divine]

[Mastery Level: 3]

[Description: Must wield a sword to activate. Creates a pillar of sword light that will destroy everything that dares to block its path.]

Ding!

<Heaven Splitting Sword Strike's limiter has been released. You may now adjust the technique's strength to your desire>

<Heavenly Domain Mastery Level has been increased (1 → 2)>

[Heavenly Domain]

[Rank: Divine]

[Mastery Level: 2]

[Description: Holding absolute authority within your domain, dominate the battlefield, and pressure your enemies with the Heavenly Domain!]

All of Yuan's main techniques saw a boost in strength and mastery.

However, what surprised him the most was the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike, which had been limited this entire time.

'Does this mean I can pour all of my Qi into a single attack?'

Yuan turned to look at Xiao Hua and said, "It appears that the limiter for the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike has been released. What happens now?"

"That means Brother Yuan can adjust the strength of the technique as he pleases. It can be as weak as a Mortal-rank technique or as powerful as even the most powerful technique in the world. However, that will depend on how much spiritual energy you can give it."

"Is that so? How powerful do you think I can make the technique at my current level?" He then asked.

She pondered for a moment before speaking, "If Brother Yuan uses all of his spiritual energy, he should be able to erase half of this sect with ease."

"T-That powerful?" Yuan was shocked.

The Spirit Healing Academy is as vast as multiple large cities. If he can destroy half of it, he can easily destroy an entire city with a single Heaven Splitting Sword Strike.

"Hm? Wait a second. If the limiter is already released, that means it can't get any stronger, right? However, it seems like I can still make it stronger. What happens then?"

"The technique will become more efficient, meaning you will be able to gather more strength with less spiritual energy. The speed at which you charge it will also increase."

"I see... That makes sense." Yuan nodded.

"I also learned the Heaven Sealing Technique. This means I can seal someone's cultivation as long as they are Spirit King and below. Can this be reverted?"

Xiao Hua nodded, "Yes, it can be reverted. Do you want to try the technique on Xiao Hua?"

"Are you sure? It won't hurt?"

"It doesn't hurt. It will only restrict Xiao Hua's cultivation base."

"Okay. I'll try it out."

"The Heaven Sealing Technique doesn't require you to touch the target. As long as they are within 10 meters of your location, you can seal their cultivation."

After taking a deep breath, Yuan activated the Heaven Sealing Technique on Xiao Hua.

Invisible golden chains that can only be seen by Yuan started appearing around Xiao Hua's petite body. However, right as the chains touched Xiao Hua's body, they all shattered without any resistance.

<Heaven Sealing Technique has failed. The target's cultivation surpasses your limit>

"What's wrong, Brother Yuan?" Xiao Hua asked him a moment later.

"Uhh... The technique failed."

"Huh?" Xiao Hua raised her eyebrows in a puzzled manner.

"Xiao Hua, are you, by any chance, suppressing your cultivation? At my current level, the technique only works on Spirit Kings and below, and you're clearly a Spirit King."

However, Xiao Hua shook her head and said, "Xiao Hua isn't suppressing her cultivation."

"That's weird... Hm? Wait a moment. When I first met you, you were only at the 3rd level. When did you reach the 9th level of Spirit King?"

"Now that Brother Yuan mentions it... Xiao Hua doesn't know either. It just felt so natural that Xiao Hua didn't even realize her cultivation had improved." Xiao Hua said.

Yuan pondered with a slight frown on his face, 'Xiao Hua wouldn't lie to me. Is her cultivation being suppressed without her knowledge? But who would do such a thing? She doesn't appear to be cursed, either. And why did her cultivation suddenly increase? What's going on?'

Xiao Hua looked at her own hands and also pondered about this phenomenon that was happening to her body.

However, no matter how much she thought about it, nothing came to her mind.

"Well, there's nothing we can do if you don't know anything. Maybe we'll find out more as we ascend the Nine Heavens." Yuan said sometime later.

"Okay." Xiao Hua nodded.

"Yuan!" A familiar voice suddenly resounded, causing Yuan to turn around.

In the distance, he could see Sect Master Xiahou flying towards him with an urgent look on her face.

"What's the matter?" He asked her a moment later.

"I just received information that the Universal Music Academy had learned of your presence here, and they are currently making their way here as we speak!" She said.

"Universal Music Academy? What do they have anything to do with me?" Yuan asked.

"Have you already forgotten that you killed their Sect Master not long ago? They are here to seek revenge!"

Yuan rubbed his eyes and sighed, "What a pain in the ass. I thought my last warning to them would be enough to make the stay away from me, but alas, they're as dumb as their deceased Sect Master."

Chapter 938 - Let Them Die!

Chapter 938 - Let Them Die!

"A-Are you going to kill them?" Sect Master Xiahou asked him in a nervous voice.

"Do you want me to kill them?" Yuan responded with a question.

"Of course not. However, I doubt you even care. After all, they are after your life."

Yuan smiled and said, "Then how about this? I will give you the chance to talk them out of killing me. If you can do that, I won't have to kill them."

"Are you serious?" Sect Master Xiahou looked at him with wide eyes.

"Of course. I am not a bloodthirsty maniac who enjoys killing, even though you probably see me as one. I only shed blood when I have no other choices."

"Very well. I will do my best to convince them to stand down." Sect Master Xiahou nodded with a serious expression.

After returning to her room, Sect Master Xiahou contacted the other Sect Masters regarding the matter.

"We have already warned the Universal Music Academy to give up on revenge multiple times, but they refuse to listen to us. If that's the case, just let them all die." Sect Master Li said.

"Yuan gave you the chance to talk them out of it? Even if that's the case, they still won't listen to you. I agree with Sect Master Li. Just let them die."

"Unfortunately, I agree with the idea to just let them die."

"If the Universal Music Academy is gone, there will no longer be any need for us to deal with their Sect Master's death, which will save us headaches, not to mention how much money it will save us in the future."

In the end, the other Sect Masters expressed the same opinion—to let the Universal Music Academy perish.

This way, they will save resources along other things.

Sect Master Xiahou felt dejected afterward. After all, she wanted to save these disciples.

"While Sun Hao deserved to die, these disciples do not deserve such a pointless death. The other Sect Masters may not want to save them, but I want to at least try."

Sect Master Xiahou hopped onto her flying treasure and left the sect to meet up with the disciples of the Universal Music Academy.

Meanwhile, Yuan and Wang Xiuying laid beside the medicine fields and talked about their adventures. Of course, since Wang Xiuying had spent most of her time practicing Alchemy, it was mostly Yuan who did the talking.

"By the way, you said that you'd joined the sect for me. What was that about?" Yuan remembered and asked her.

Wang Xiuying blushed and revealed the truth to him.

"You joined the sect and learned Alchemy just to help me? I am really flattered, but you really don't need to do this... I have already robbed enough people of their time over the past decades. Xiuying, please, just do whatever you want... for yourself." Yuan sighed after learning everything.

Wang Xiuying shook her head and said, "You have no idea how much your music saved me, Yuan. Even after your retirement, your music continued to

motivate me every single day. Even if it wasn't your intention, I am still grateful to you, hence why I want to help you."

"But don't worry, I am no longer pursuing Alchemy just to help you. I have another goal now."

"Oh? What's that?"

"There's someone I want to surpass, and I won't stop until that goal is achieved. However, that doesn't mean I don't want to help you anymore!"

"Your servant may be much better in Alchemy than me now, but I am still your nurse in the real world!"

"Yuan, I heard that you'd created a faction. I want to join it!"

"Huh? You want to join the Demon Sealing Faction?"

"Demon Sealing Faction? What a weird name. But yes, I do. All factions have a medical team. I will be in your medical team!"

"We don't actually have a medical team. The faction consists of 10 members including me, and they're only good at fighting... Except for Meixiu, who also deals with our food and some of the chores."

"I see... Then I will be the first member of your medical team! If you doubt my credentials, I can—"

"There's no need." Yuan smiled.

"If you want to join, I won't refuse. However, we currently live on a very secluded mountain. Unless you live with us, it won't be very convenient for us to meet."

"I heard. The Dragon Spiral Mountain, right? I tried visiting you once, but I was immediately turned away."

"Huh? Why didn't you just give us a call? We could've probably worked something out."

"I didn't want to bother you."

"Anyways, I will speak with my grandfather later about leaving his hospital permanently to work with you guys."

"If that's your decision." Yuan nodded.

"Anyways, do you want to listen to some music? It's been a while since I have played the instrument."

"Of course! I would never miss the chance to listen to your music!" Wang Xiuying immediately nodded.

Yuan retrieved the Soul Ensnaring Zither and started playing it.

A couple of hours away from the Spirit Healing Academy, Sect Master Xiahou finally encountered the disciples from the Universal Music Academy.

"Stop! I am the Sect Master of the Spirit Healing Academy, and I wish to speak with you!" She stood before their army that consisted of over 10,000 disciples.

Although the Universal Music Academy had over 100,000 disciples, they decided to not bring anyone below Spirit Master, as they would only be a hindrance.

"Greetings, Sect Master Xiahou. I am Elder Chen, who will be replacing Sect Master Sun in the near future. We only have one objective—the bastard that killed our Sect Master! If you're worried that we might damage your sect, please be at ease. We will not enter your sect, only surround it from the outside, and we will only attack once our target leaves your sect."

"Future? This future that you speak of will not exist if you stubbornly insist on avenging Sect Master Sun's death! I am here in hopes to convince you all to turn back!" Sect Master Xiahou said in a loud and clear voice that could be heard by everyone there.

Chapter 939 - Confronting the Universal Music Academy

Chapter 939 - Confronting the Universal Music Academy

"Sect Master Xiahou, no matter how many times you try to convince us, our conviction and determination to avenge our Sect Master will not change! We will kill the bastard that killed our Sect Master! The only way to stop us is if you kill us all right here and now!" Elder Chen exclaimed in a loud voice.

Sect Master Xiahou rubbed her temples and sighed, feeling like she was dealing with children who can only listen but not comprehend her words.

"Listen. You won't even get the chance to avenge your Sect Master. I don't need to kill you because you'll all die if you try to kill Yuan."

"You don't know the true horror of his strength since you were not there to witness it, but the man who killed your Sect Master is not someone to be trifled with! Even if you bring 10,000 experts, he will easily kill all of you without breaking a sweat! If you're just going there to die, you might as well kill yourselves right now. At least that will save you some time and headaches."

"Hmph! I heard that man is only a peak Spirit Lord! We have two Spirit Kings and fifty Spirit Lords here! Not to mention our Spirit Masters, which is over 9,000! Are you saying that he, as a peak Spirit Lord, is strong enough to defeat all of us?! That's ridiculous!"

Sect Master Xiahou frowned and said, "I will warn you one last time. Turn around and leave! Otherwise, you'll be walking straight to your deaths!"

"I refuse!" Elder Chen declared in a booming voice that made the blood of the disciples behind him boil with excitement.

"I should've listened to the other Sect Masters. They were all willing to let you die without even giving you a chance. Unfortunately, I have wasted my time by coming here. I will tell Yuan to meet you guys outside the sect. I don't want my disciples to clean your corpses afterward."

Sect Master Xiahou shook her head and began flying back to the sect.

Once she got close to the Spirit Healing Academy, she could hear very pleasant music coming from somewhere within the sect.

'This sounds like the zither. Who could be playing right now? Not even Sect Master Sun could compare to this person even during his prime days.' Sect Master Xiahou could feel her body getting more energetic as she listened to the music.

The music eventually led her to Wang Xiuying's hill.

'It's him? He can also play the zither with such mastery? Just what is his background?' Sect Master Xiahou was shocked to see Yuan playing the zither for Wang Xiuying.

After staying in the air to listen to Yuan's music for many minutes, Sect Master Xiahou snapped out of her daze and finally descended beside him.

However, she didn't interrupt his current song and waited until he was finished before she began speaking, "I have tried to convince the Universal Music Academy to turn around, but they have refused to listen to my warnings. They have two Spirit Kings, fifty Spirit Lords, and over 9,000 Spirit Masters."

"Is that so?" Yuan mumbled.

He turned to look at Wang Xiuying and said, "Sorry, but I have to leave for a bit right now. Don't worry, I should be back very soon."

"What's happening? Where are you going?" She asked with a worried expression on her face.

Judging by the atmosphere and her Master's expression, Wang Xiuying knew that Yuan was involved in some bad business again.

"Your Master can explain it to you." Yuan smiled.

He then asked, "Which direction?"

Sect Master Xiahou pointed south.

Yuan didn't linger any longer and immediately disappeared towards the south.

"Master! What's happening?! Please tell me!"

Sect Master Xiahou sighed and said, "I told you that Yuan had killed the Sect Master of the Universal Music Academy, right? Well, they're here for revenge."

"What?! And you're going to let him fight them?! Can't you and the other Sect Masters do something about this?!"

She shook her head and sighed, "We tried. Multiple times. Unfortunately, they did not heed our warnings."

"No way..." Wang Xiuying mumbled.

Meanwhile, Yuan and the Universal Music Academy flew towards each other.

"Young Master, should I help you kill these ignorant fools?" Feng Yuxiang asked.

"No, Xiao Hua will kill them."

"No, I will handle them by myself. This is a mess that I'd created, after all." He immediately refused their help.

Sometime later, Yuan could see the Universal Music Academy and their ten-thousand-strong army of disciples.

Yuan took a deep breath and retrieved the Empyrean Overlord.

The moment Yuan noticed the Universal Music Academy, they also noticed him.

"It's him! That's the bastard that killed our Sect Master!" Some of the disciples recognized Yuan from when he visited their sect to threaten them for Sun Hao's location.

"Everyone! The bastard that killed our Sect Master has appeared! Prepare for battle!" Elder Chen shouted out loud, alerting everyone there.

However, before they could even do anything, Elder Chen suddenly shouted again, "W-Wait! He's doing something!"

Since they were still very far away from each other, Elder Chen was unable to see Yuan's figure very well. However, he can clearly see Yuan lifting his arms into the sky, and he appeared to be holding something that was almost the size of his own body.

After hovering there without moving for a few moments, Yuan suddenly swung whatever he was holding in their direction.

"Shit! Scatter! SCATTER!" Elder Chen roared in a panicked voice, but alas, it was too late.

The following moment, the massive beam of sword light released by Yuan had reached their location, instantly consuming half of the disciples there.

The disciples that were consumed by this sword light were all disintegrated until there were not even ashes left.

Elder Chen had barely survived Yuan's Heaven Splitting Sword Strike, but he did not feel relieved even in the slightest, and his wide eyes could only stare at the destruction that was left behind by the devastating attack, which

looked even worse than a battlefield that had raged on for thousands of years.

'This bastard... Is he even human...?' Elder Chen wondered inwardly.

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Chapter 940 - 10,000 Corpses

Chapter 940 - 10,000 Corpses

Elder Chen and the rest of the disciples that survived the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike did not dare to move as their widened eyes stared at the devastating destruction before their eyes.

They have never seen such destruction before— at least not from a single attack.

In the blink of an eye, half of their 10,000 army was vanquished.

While the Universal Music Academy were in a daze, Yuan shouted at them, "This is your last chance to give up on revenge and go back to your sect! If you continue being stubborn, then I will truly show no mercy and kill every last one of you!"

The disciples' bodies trembled in fear upon hearing Yuan's words, but Elder Chen gritted his teeth and shouted back, "Do not be afraid! Do not falter! Do not listen to his empty threats! There's no way he can still fight after releasing such a powerful attack! He must be out of spiritual energy now! Forward! Kill him and avenge our fellow disciples and our Sect Master!"

The disciples regained their courage after hearing Elder Chen's words. They all believed that Yuan would have little to no more spiritual energy left after such a big attack.

Seeing the disciples charging at him, Yuan took a deep breath.

"What a pity."

[Ten Thousand Ghost Blades!]

Ten thousand copies of Starry Abyss suddenly appeared in the sky, causing the disciples to halt.

"W-What the hell!? I thought he had no more spiritual energy!" The disciples were shocked to see so many daggers appearing out of thin air.

"It's just an illusion! Keep going!" Elder Chen shouted as he led the disciples.

Yuan closed his eyes and motioned for the daggers to fly.

Whoosh!

All ten thousand daggers flew towards the disciples like a meteor shower.

A single dagger had the strength of a Spirit Lord, so it was as though ten thousand Spirit Lords had appeared in the battlefield.

"Run! He's a monster!"

When the disciples saw how effortlessly Yuan was killing them, the surviving disciples towards the end of their formation turned around and started running away.

"Where do you idiots think you're going?! Get back here and fight!" Elder Chen roared at those that ran away, but none of them turned around.

Unfortunately, he was too busy dealing with the flying daggers to chase after them.

With that being said, even though Elder Chen was unable to stop them, there were more than enough flying daggers to chase after the disciples that ran away.

'I gave them plenty of chances, but none of them took it. Even if you suddenly decide to change your mind, I have already made up my mind. Everyone here will die today.' Yuan sighed inwardly.

The loud noises caused by the fighting and the screaming quickly became weaker and weaker, until there was nobody left.

It has been less than five minutes since Yuan showed up, but he'd managed to kill all of the disciples that came after him without sparing a single life.

Yuan opened his eyes again after the battle, and he looked at the bloodstained battlefield with a profound expression on his face.

"Do you guys think I am a hypocrite? Even though I keep saying that I do not enjoy killing people, I always end up with blood in my hands." He suddenly spoke out loud.

"No, the Young Master has done nothing wrong. You gave them many warnings and chances to turn around, but they ignored it. If you warn someone to not enter a burning building but they still decide to anyway, that is entirely their fault, even if you were the one who lit the building ablaze." Feng Yuxiang said in a calm voice.

"Don't think too much about it, Brother Yuan. This is the true nature of the cultivation world. You either kill them or they kill you. There is no need to feel guilty about it." Xiao Hua said.

"Sorry, but I cannot lie and say that I understand your feelings, Yuan. As a Divine Beast, I don't see anything wrong with killing those that wish to harm you." Lan Yingying said.

"Thank you." Yuan said to them.

And he sighed inwardly, 'Maybe I am just worried that killing too many people will change me— change Yuan.'

After taking another look at the chaos he'd caused, Yuan turned around and flew back to the Spirit Healing Academy.

"Are you not going to loot their bodies, Young Master? You might find something nice with so many corpses here." Feng Yuxiang suddenly asked.

"I don't feel like it. And it's too bloody down there." Yuan said without even looking back.

"Yuan! Are you okay?!" Wang Xiuying rushed to him the moment he returned.

"Yes, as you can see, I am totally fine." He said with a smile.

However, Wang Xiuying did not smile. Instead, she frowned.

"Who do you think you're trying to fool? Despite my young age, I have dealt with all sorts of patients in my grandfather's hospital. I can tell if someone is hurt or not by looking at their eyes, and when I look into your eyes, I can tell that you're not fine. You may be fine physically, but not mentally, and mental damage is just as dangerous as physical injuries, sometimes even more severe."

"I'll give you some time for now, but I will eventually ask you about it."

"Thanks." The smile on Yuan's face became less stiff after hearing her words.

"Hey... The Universal Music Academy... What happened to them?" Sect Master Xiahou asked him afterward.

"I killed them. Every last one of them." Yuan responded in a calm yet cold voice, sending shivers down their backs.

And he continued, "Oh, I didn't touch the bodies. If you want, you can go ahead and loot them. It'd be a waste to leave them behind."

"I-I will send some disciples there later..." Sect Master Xiahou nodded her head in a dazed voice.

'It hasn't even been that long since he left and he's already killed all 10,000 of them? Utterly ridiculous...' She was terrified inwardly, yet she was also relieved that she didn't offend this monster like Sun Hao had.

Chapter 941 - Playing Catch

Chapter 941 - Playing Catch

"Xiuying, I'm going to leave earlier than expected. Sorry for all of the troubles that I had caused you and this sect." Yuan suddenly said to her.

"Huh? Why?"

"I have a feeling that something will happen soon, and I don't want you or this sect to get caught up in it, so I'm going to leave. Don't worry, we'll see each other again on the other side sooner or later." He smiled.

"Okay..." She nodded.

Wang Xiuying logged off Cultivation Online sometime later while Yuan traveled to the Stairway to Heaven.

"Xiao Hua." He suddenly called for her when he arrived.

"Yes?" She appeared beside him and proceeded to stare at him with a pondering gaze.

"Let's play catch."

"Huh?" Xiao Hua's eyes widened with surprise.

"I promised to play catch with you again, remember? Let's do it now. I still have a couple of days before I have to leave for my sister's birthday." Yuan smiled.

"Un!"

Xiao Hua's face immediately became filled with bliss, and she retrieved the red ball they used before.

"There's no need to hold back this time. And let's get some distance." Yuan said to her before flying a few hundred meters away.

Xiao Hua also flew into the air shortly after.

Once they were ready, Xiao Hua tossed the red ball at Yuan with all of her strength.

The red ball disappeared the instant it left her hands, and it appeared in front of Yuan faster than one could blink, almost as though the ball had teleported.

PA!

A loud noise resounded as Yuan caught the ball with his bare hands, and he was pushed back a few meters by the impact.

"I'm really glad you held back before. If you'd used your full strength when we first met, I would've definitely died a horrible death." Yuan smiled as he looked at the ball, his hands trembling from it.

"Let me go back a bit further!" He said to her before increasing their distance by a couple hundred more meters.

Whoosh!

Yuan tossed the ball back at Xiao Hua using 50 percent of his strength, as he was worried that he might accidentally hurt her.

The red ball flew faster than a bullet, and a single streak of red light appeared in the sky.

However, Xiao Hua casually caught the ball with a single hand, and she said afterward, "There's no need to hold back, Brother Yuan."

And she proceeded to throw the ball back at him.

'T-That was even stronger than her first throw! Is she subconsciously holding back?' Yuan wondered to himself after catching the ball that felt a lot heavier.

'And what kind of material is this ball made out of? To withstand such abuse...'

The two of them would spend the next few hours playing catch ball, and by the time they were done, the trees beneath them were all bent in an unnatural manner due to the pressure caused by their game.

"It's been a while since I've worked up so much sweat. Let's do this again tomorrow." Yuan said to her afterward.

"Okay." Xiao Hua eagerly nodded.

Yuan logged off shortly after to have dinner with the others.

Meanwhile, Wang Xiuying spoke to her grandfather about joining Yuan's faction during dinner.

"So I have decided to join Yu Tian's faction and move in with him at the Dragon Spiral Mountain. However, this means that I won't be able to work at the hospital any longer. What do you think, grandpa?"

"The Young Master created a faction? When?" Doctor Wang raised his eyebrows.

"A while ago. You've probably heard of it. It's called the Demon Sealing Faction."

"Huh? I have heard of it, but that's Player Yuan's faction, isn't it?"

"Hm? Oh, right. You didn't know. Well, Yu Tian is Player Yuan."

Doctor Wang's mouth dropped wide open after hearing this.

"R-Really? And how long have you known about this?"

"For a while. I promised to keep it a secret for him, so I didn't tell you. But I got his permission today to tell you."

"Unbelievable... To think that famous Player Yuan was the Young Master all along!"

"Make sure you keep it a secret, grandpa. It would be troublesome for him if the public learned of his identity." Wang Xiuying said.

"That's only obvious."

"Anyways, what do you say? Can I go?"

Doctor Wang nodded, "Yes, you can go. You're big enough to make your own decisions and move out. As for the hospital, don't worry about it. You were never an official employee, and you went there on your own accord. Though, the people there will miss you, especially the patients."

"When do you plan on moving?"

"Soon. I need to apply for his faction at the Cultivators' Association first. I'll do it tomorrow."

The following day, Wang Xiuying made her way to the Cultivators' Association.

Although one can join a faction without visiting the Cultivators' Association, they would not be considered an 'official' member of the faction by the Cultivators' Association and would not be allowed to participate in official events.

After arriving at the Cultivators' Association, Wang Xiuying patiently waited until she was at the front desk.

"I'd like to apply for a faction," she said to the woman working at the desk.

"Name of the faction?"

"Demon Sealing Faction!"

The woman raised her eyebrows after hearing this familiar name, and she looked at Wang Xiuying with a pitiful gaze.

"You know... I'm saying this for your own good, but you won't get accepted into that faction. Countless people have applied for the faction, but they have not approved of a single new member since its founding."

"If you ask me, these people are too arrogant. Just because they have that Player Yuan with them, they think they can exist with 10 members. What a joke! They're looking down on all of the factions out there!"

Wang Xiuying was speechless. She didn't expect so many people to apply for the faction, but considering Yuan's popularity, it wasn't surprising at all.

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Chapter 942 - Applying for the Demon Sealing Faction

Chapter 942 - Applying for the Demon Sealing Faction

"Thank you for the warning, but I would still like to apply to that faction." Wang Xiuying said with a smile on her face.

The woman shrugged, "You're only wasting your time. Don't say I didn't warn you."

"Name?" The woman proceeded to ask her a few questions required for the application form.

"Wang Xiuying."

"Age?"

"19 years old."

"Your cultivation?"

"Sixth level Spirit Apprentice."

The woman scoffed inwardly after hearing Wang Xiuying's cultivation. The Demon Sealing Faction consisted mostly of high-level Spirit Warriors. There was no way they'd accept a Spirit Apprentice into their ranks.

"Reason for wanting to join the faction?"

"Because I want to help them." Wang Xiuying calmly responded.

"..."

The woman shook her head inwardly. 'This girl... she's hopeless.'

After typing in all of Wang Xiuying's information, the woman sent the application to the Demon Sealing Faction.

"We will give you a call if they accept you, but like I'd said, that won't happen, so you might as well apply for another faction while you're here." The woman said.

However, Wang Xiuying suddenly retrieved her phone and dialed a number.

A few moments later—

"Yes, I have just applied for the faction. Thanks. I'll talk to you again once I return home."

Before Wang Xiuying even hung up the phone, the woman noticed a change on her screen, causing her to look at the monitor.

"W-What?! T-This is! Approved?! Impossible!" The woman couldn't believe her eyes when she saw the status of Wang Xiuying's application that had suddenly changed from pending to approved!

'This isn't possible! There must have been an error in the system!' The woman didn't want to believe it.

After all, over a million people have applied to join the Demon Sealing Faction since it was announced, but all of their applications have remained 'pending' even to this day.

"Is there something wrong?" Wang Xiuying asked the woman after noticing her facial expression.

"T-There has been a bug in the system. It says that your application had been approved, but I'd just submitted it. There's no way that's possible." The woman said.

And she continued, "Please wait while I call my supervisor."

"Uhh..." Wang Xiuying wanted to tell the woman that it wasn't an error and that Meixiu had manually approved it during her call just now, but the woman was already on the phone and speaking to her supervisor.

Of course, when the supervisor heard of the situation, he also believed it to be a bug in the system, so he manually removed Wang Xiuying's name from the Demon Sealing Faction's member list, bringing it back down to 10.

"I apologize for the inconvenience, but I will have to resubmit your application due to an error."

"Huh? Even though it was already approved?" Wang Xiuying was speechless.

The woman scoffed in a mocking manner, "Do you really believe that you'll be able to join the faction because of an error? Even though your name had temporarily appeared in their database, we easily removed it."

Wang Xiuying rubbed her eyes and sighed, "That wasn't an error."

"Yeah, yeah. Whatever you say. Anyways, I have finished submitting your application."

Wang Xiuying didn't want to argue with this woman, so she just left the building.

Once she was outside, she called Meixiu again, "Hey, sorry, but something happened at the Cultivators' Association and I had to resubmit my application."

"But I already approved it. Your name is already in our roster— Eh? It's gone? It was just there." Meixiu's puzzled voice resounded through the phone.

"They thought it was an error, so they removed me from the list..." Wang Xiuying explained the situation to her.

"I see... Then I'll give Chairman Lee a call to make sure there isn't any misunderstanding this time."

"Thank you."

After hanging up the phone, Meixiu called Chairman Lee and notified him of the situation.

"I-I am so sorry for the inconvenience my people have caused you! I will immediately send out an email so that it won't happen again!" Chairman Lee said.

Once the call ended, Chairman Lee hastily sent an email to all of his associates regarding Wang Xiuying being the Demon Sealing Faction's newest member. He also made sure to scold the woman and her supervisor for their hasty actions.

News of the Demon Sealing Faction receiving a new member quickly spread, shocking the world.

"What? The Demon Sealing Faction with Player Yuan finally got a new member after ignoring everyone for months? Who's this lucky bastard?"

"It's a woman. According to the person that did her application, she is a young lady between 18 and 20 years old."

"What? That's all? As the one who did the application, she should have way more information on this new member, right?"

"That is against their policy, and I doubt she would want to offend the Demon Sealing Faction by revealing their private information."

"Damn! What is so special about this new member that the others don't have?! I sent an application the day their faction was announced, but I still haven't received a response! I'd rather they deny it than to ignore it!"

Meanwhile, Wang Xiuying called Meixiu again after she returned home.

"So when can I move into the headquarters?" Wang Xiuying asked.

"We'll need to speak with the Manager first. Fortunately, she's currently living here as a guest, so it shouldn't take too long." Meixiu said.

"I will leave it to you and Yuan. Once again, thank you for letting me join the faction."

"It's only natural. You're Yuan's friend, and you even took care of him before."

After the call ended, Meixiu went to look for the Manager, who was watching the sealed demon in the training area like a guard dog.

"Your faction received a new member?"

"Yes, so can you make it so that she can enter the Dragon Spiral Mountain? She'll be living with us."

The Manager narrowed her eyes and said, "I will think about it... after your boyfriend deals with this final demon."

"B-Boyfriend?" Meixiu blushed.

"Am I wrong? I can smell his odor all over your body— and that Chu girl."

"..." Meixiu was speechless.

'The Manager can smell Yuan on us? That's... so embarrassing!' She cried inwardly.

"Hm? You didn't know? I guess he has been two-timing you..." The Manager smiled when she noticed Meixiu's stiff expression.

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AN: Check out my new novel 'Magic System in a Parallel World'. I will give a bonus CO chapter for every 1,000 vote the new novel gets.

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Chapter 943 - It's a Mutual Thing

Chapter 943 - It's a Mutual Thing

"I guess not even the famous Player Yuan is perfect. But nobody would expect him to be an unfaithful bastard." The Manager sneered in disdain.

"M-Mutual..." Meixiu suddenly mumbled in a low voice.

"Huh? What did you just say?"

"I already know about it, so does Lulu. In fact, it's a mutual thing between the three of us." Meixiu explained.

"A-Are you serious?" The Manager stared at Meixiu with a look of disbelief on her face.

In her eyes, Meixiu didn't appear to be the type of woman to share a man with other women.

However, Meixiu nodded her head, confirming everything.

"You're actually willing to share him? Unbelievable..." The Manager muttered in shock.

"I mean, both Lulu and I love him, and he loves us. In case you forgot, I am only supposed to stand by his side as his servant. The fact that he is willing to accept me as his woman is already more than anything I can ask for. And it's normal for a powerful man to have many wives, right?"

The Manager rubbed her eyes and sighed, "Listen here. While it's true that most families here have multiple wives, they are also much older than you guys. You may be an adult legally at the age of 18, but you guys do not

have the experience of adults. In fact, you're all babies in my eyes. It's too early for you ladies to share a man."

Meixiu sighed, "I was against this kind of lifestyle at first too, but I have already made a decision. As long as I can stay by his side, I don't care how many women he sees."

The Manager narrowed her eyes at Meixiu.

After a moment of silence, she sighs, "Whatever. I don't have the right to tell you how to live your life, anyway. Even if you decide to get knocked up by Yuan tomorrow, I won't complain."

"W-What? Knocked up? T-That's definitely too early for us!" Meixiu exclaimed.

"Hmph. Judging by the strong scent on your body, I assume that you guys do it pretty often. Hell, I can even smell him inside your—I mean, if you keep messing around, you'll eventually get knocked up."

Meixiu looked at the Manager with wide eyes, and she wondered to herself, 'What kind of nose does she have? Even dogs can't compare to her!'

"Anyways, if you want your friend to enter the mountain, you better tell Yuan to hurry up and deal with this demon!" The Manager said in a stubborn voice.

"I understand. I will talk to him."

The Manager watched in silence as Meixiu returned to the house.

"To think they'd be in such a relationship... Truly unbelievable. What do they even see in that irritating brat? He's talented... really talented, I will give him that, but besides his talent, there is nothing special about him!" She sighed inwardly.

Sometime later, Meixiu went to speak with Yuan, repeating what the Manager said to her.

"I see... Well, if that's the case, we'll move our schedule up a little. I have nothing else to do, anyway." Yuan said.

During dinner, Yuan told everyone about the situation.

"I won't mind even if we start the training now." Wang Ming said in an excited voice.

"So we finally have a new member, huh. Who is this person?" Shi Lang asked.

"I will introduce you to her when she arrives." Yuan said.

"Her? Don't tell me it's another girlfriend!" Wu Zao exclaimed.

Yuan smiled, "She's a dear friend and someone who helped me through some dark times in the past."

The others turned silent after hearing his last few words, and they recalled his past as a cripple.

After dinner, Meixiu approached Yuan and whispered in his ears, "Can you sleep with me tonight?"

Yuan smiled, "This is the first time you've invited me. Of course."

Meixiu blushed and silently nodded her head before running back to her room.

After returning to his room, Yuan said to Chu Liuxiang, "I'll be with Meixiu tonight."

"Sure. I will need as much rest as I can get if we're going to start training tomorrow, after all." She said in a casual and calm manner.

Sometime later, Yuan went to knock on Meixiu's door.

"Come inside."

Yuan twisted the doorknob and entered the room, but it was pitch black inside with the only light being the slight moonlight that peeked through the windows.

But despite the darkness, Yuan was able to see her figure with his divine sense.

"Meixiu?" Yuan called for her.

"..."

A few seconds later, Meixiu walked into where the moonlight shone, revealing herself.

"..."

Yuan was dumbfounded after seeing Meixiu's appearance, who was currently half naked and wearing only a pair of exotic black lingerie.

"M-Meixiu? Are you okay?"

She nodded and spoke in a bashful voice, "To tell you the truth, even though I accepted our unique relationship, I never truly understood it."

"I always thought I was mature. While it's true that I am more mature and experienced than most people around my age, I am still inexperienced in many things."

Yuan smiled and said, "Did the Manager say something weird to you?"

"No, she made me realize something. While I don't mind sharing you with other women, I also don't want to lose to them. Even if you love us all equally, I want to be the first name that appears in your head when you think of us."

Meixiu started approaching Yuan.

Once she was in front of him, she gave him a passionate kiss on the lips before pulling him to the bed and stripping him naked.

"By the way, I got something new I want to try out."

"What is it?"

Meixiu showed him the new product she got from the convenience store a while ago.

"What's that? Medicine?" Yuan raised an eyebrow.

"I got it from the convenience store. The clerk said it's a stimulator that will make things more enjoyable. Don't worry, it's completely safe."

"Sure. Let's do it." Yuan trusted Meixiu and agreed.

After taking out two red capsules, they each swallowed one.

"My body feels hot... especially down there..." The effects of the capsule immediately started affecting Meixiu moments after she consumed it.

As for Yuan, although it took a little longer to affect him, the sword between his legs hardened like never before.

"Yuan..." Meixiu mumbled his name in an enchanting voice before kissing him again.

Yuan kissed her back while embracing her body tightly.

Thus, the beginning of a long night.

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Chapter 944 - Love Capsule

Chapter 944 - Love Capsule

"Haaa... haaa... haaa..." Meixiu gasped for air as she laid on the bed with her entire body soaked in sweat and other fluids.

"How long does this medicine last? We've been at it for 4 hours now, but my body is still unwilling to calm down..." Yuan asked her as he stood beside the bed, the sword between his legs as stiff as ever, almost as though they didn't even do anything.

"I... I don't know... but my body is still... craving for it..." Meixiu said.

"Let's take a break... As enjoyable as the last 4 hours has been, I don't want this to harm our bodies."

"Okay..."

Yuan laid on the bed beside Meixiu shortly after.

Despite the both of them still being naked, Meixiu didn't shy away and snuggled with him.

"Yuan, I love you..." Meixiu suddenly mumbled in a low voice.

"I love you, too." Yuan smiled.

"You know, the Manager said we're too young to be doing this..."

"Is that why you decided to do all of this?"

"No, I have been wanting to do this with you for a while, but I never had the courage. What the Manager said is right. I'm still too young and inexperienced to become a proper partner for you. Therefore, I am going to work hard to become—"

Yuan suddenly poked her face and interrupted, "I don't need you to change or become someone else for me. Just keep being you— keep being the woman I fell in love with, okay? So what if you're young and inexperienced? We all have to start from somewhere, right?"

After a moment of silence, Meixiu nodded her head.

"By the way, what should we tell Yu Rou? Should we tell her about our relationship?" Meixiu suddenly asked.

"I don't mind. What about you?"

"Well... I am a little hesitant..." Meixiu sighed.

"Hesitant? Why?"

"Well, it's no secret that Yu Rou really treasures you as her brother. I don't know why, but I have a feeling that she might not approve of our relationship. Perhaps we should postpone telling her about our relationship. I don't want to ruin her birthday, either."

Yuan pondered for a moment before nodding, "Let's do just that, then. It's Yu Rou's birthday, so everything on that day should be about her, not us."

"Thank you, Yuan..."

Meixiu suddenly felt a strong urge to caress Yuan's chest.

Her hands subconsciously moved, gently caressing him with her beautiful fingers.

"I can't hold it any longer..." Meixiu suddenly said.

She sat up on the bed and crawled on top of Yuan's body.

"We're supposed to be taking a break..." Yuan showed a helpless smile.

"We are still taking a break. I'm just going to use my mouth, that's all."

"That's not... Oh..."

Yuan halted his words to let out a satisfied sound when he felt something incredibly soft and warm wrap around his sword, even sucking on it.

A few minutes later, Yuan could no longer endure it any longer and pounced on Meixiu, ending their short break.

The two of them would keep up their intimate acts with each other until sunrise.

"I-It's finally over..." Yuan sighed in relief when the stiff rod between his legs was no more, as it was fully satisfied after an entire night of intercourse.

He looked at Meixiu, who had fallen asleep on the bed from exhaustion just minutes ago.

Fortunately, she knocked out after cleaning herself and the bed, or she would be sleeping in all sorts of fluids. With that being said, only the bed was clean, so the floor and the walls were still dirty.

As for how they managed to mess up a perfectly clean room after a night of intercourse, only the two of them would know.

After tucking Meixiu in bed, Yuan went downstairs and said to the others, "Meixiu is a bit sick right now, so we'll have to eat breakfast at the mall, and she won't be participating in today's training."

"Is she okay?" Wang Bingbing asked.

"Yes, she'll be fine after a day of rest." Yuan calmly nodded.

Who knows how they'll react if he told them the truth—that Meixiu was too exhausted to move because they'd spent the entire night together.

As they made their way to the mall for breakfast, Chu Liuxiang approached Yuan and whispered to him, "So... Is Meixiu really sick, or is there a different reason as to why she can't get out of bed?"

Yuan smiled and said, "We did it all night."

"You what?! The entire night?" Chu Liuxiang was in disbelief.

"Yes. From the moment I entered her room... until sunrise."

Chu Liuxiang stared at him with wide eyes.

"H-How? We are normally done after two hours! How did you last an entire night?" She couldn't help but ask.

"Meixiu bought some weird medicine and suggested we try it, which kept our bodies active and lustful throughout the night, no matter how many times we did it! It was exhausting even for me! My whole body is sore now, especially my hips..."

"M-Medicine? That sounds suspicious as hell! Where on earth did she acquire such a thing?"

"Apparently from the convenience store at the mall. I'll go ask them after breakfast." Yuan said.

"I'll come with you." Chu Liuxiang said.

Breakfast lasted a little over an hour.

"I'll meet you guys at the training field in a bit. I have some business here. It won't take long." Yuan said to the others.

"All right. See you there." They didn't question him and left immediately.

Once they were alone, Yuan and Chu Liuxiang made their way to the convenience store that was on the first floor of the mall.

"Welcome! Oh? Are you guys new to the Dragon Spiral Mountain? I have never seen you before." The woman at the desk asked them.

"We've been here for a couple of months now." Yuan said.

"I see. Anyways, is there anything specific that you're looking for?"

"Yes, I have some questions about a certain product my friend bought from this place. I don't know the name, but they're these red capsules that 'enhances' one's body." Yuan said.

It took a moment, but when the woman realized what Yuan was talking about, she covered her mouth and chuckled, "I see, I see. I know exactly what you're talking about."

She then reached under her counter and grabbed a box of the medicine that Yuan and Meixiu used last night.

"Are these it?" She asked him.

"Yes, this is it." Yuan confirmed.

"They're called Love Capsules. If you're looking to improve your night life with your girlfriend here, you'll definitely want these. They're very popular right now, especially amongst the young adults. They're also approved by the government and many agencies, so they are very safe. Just don't consume too much at once. Three per day is the limit."

"Ummm... How long are they supposed to last?" Yuan then asked.

"About an hour or two depending on the person."

"Huh? There's no way. After all, I used it with my partner last night, and it lasted us until sunrise! We couldn't stop for ten whole hours!" Yuan said.

"W-What? Ten hours...? Are you sure? I don't think even the strongest capsule out there can last that long... Did you consume multiple at once?" The woman asked.

"No, just one for each of us." Yuan shook his head.

"Hmm..." The woman stared at the Love Capsules and began pondering.

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Chapter 945 - Killing the Last Demon

Chapter 945 - Killing the Last Demon

After pondering for some time, the woman asked, "Do you, by any chance, have a unique physique? Perhaps it's due to your physique that has increased the potency of the medicine."

Yuan then said, "While that is entirely possible, what about my partner, who had the same effects?"

The woman pondered again before asking, "Are you sure about that? While she may have lasted ten hours, it doesn't mean she's affected by the medicine. She could've just been enduring it."

Yuan swallowed nervously after hearing this possibility. He didn't confirm it with Meixiu because she kept up with him the entire night without complaining, and she even encouraged him to continue.

"I will confirm it with her later." Yuan then said.

"Thank you for your time."

"Wait! Can I have this box of Love Capsules?" Chu Liuxiang suddenly asked.

"Of course. You can have as many as you want." The woman nodded.

"Thank you! Oh, I don't need a bag. I'll just carry it home with me."

Chu Liuxiang grabbed the box and held it in her hand without feeling shameful about it.

"You want to use that as well?" Yuan asked her after they left.

"Of course! Since you did it with Meixiu, it's only fair if you do it with me as well! I also want to experience what she felt!"

"Are you sure? This medicine will keep me up for 10 hours. I don't know about Meixiu, but there's a good chance that she..."

"If Meixiu can do it, so can I! Don't underestimate me, darling!"

Sometime later, they met up with the others in the training field.

"Are you guys ready?" Yuan asked them.

"Of course!"

Yuan unsealed the demon, starting their training.

"If you can defeat my friends, I will set you free." Yuan said to the demon after unsealing it.

"You want me to listen to livestock? Hahaha! In your fucking dreams!" The demon laughed out loud.

Yuan didn't say anything else and retrieved the 10 demon cores that he'd gathered from the previous 10 demons.

When the demon saw the demon cores in Yuan's hands, it stopped laughing and began sweating profusely.

"One of these demon cores belonged to a demon with the strength of a 2nd level Spirit Lord. Killing a 5th level Spirit Master like you will be easier than taking candy from a baby." Yuan said, causing it to tremble some more.

"You can try to kill yourself, but I will seal you before then." Yuan snapped his fingers, causing the Demon Sealing Zone to activate.

Everything below the demon's neck instantly petrified.

This terrified the demon, who had severely underestimated him.

"I understand. I will do it." The demon gritted its teeth and said.

"Good."

Yuan unsealed the demon, and the first team started their training shortly after.

After an entire day of training, Yuan said to the demon before sealing it, "See you tomorrow."

"Damn! I almost died multiple times fighting this demon and it's only two levels stronger than the last one!" Wang Ming exclaimed.

"It wouldn't be training if it got easier." Yuan smiled.

Sometime later, Yuan visited Meixiu's room to find her sitting on her bed with her laptop.

"Sorry I missed training, Yuan." Meixiu said to him.

"Don't worry about it. You can do it tomorrow."

He shook his head.

"By the way, I have a question for you."

"What is it?"

"The medicine we took yesterday... Did it really last 10 hours for you?"

"..."

After a moment of silence, Meixiu sighed and said, "No, it lasted only two hours for me."

"Why didn't you tell me?"

"You looked like you were having fun, and I also enjoyed it."

Yuan sighed, "You could've gotten hurt, Meixiu."

"That wasn't my intention. Sorry."

"Are you sure you're fine?"

She nodded with a smile, "Yes. My body is a little sore, but that's all."

"The last thing I want is for you to get hurt just to satisfy me. I know you don't want to lose, but I don't want you to force yourself. Just continue being the Meixiu I know and love."

"Thank you." She nodded.

Yuan returned to his room sometime later to find Chu Liuxiang lying on the bed with the box of Love Capsules in her hands.

"You want to do it today?" Yuan asked her.

"Huh? Oh, no. I was just bored. I won't be able to participate in training tomorrow if we did it today, after all. I'll wait until training is over."

"All right."

The following morning, everyone including Meixiu gathered at the training area for training.

The training would last until it was almost Yu Rou's birthday.

"Your service is no longer required. I will now set you free." Yuan said the demon at the end of their training.

The demon sighed in relief inwardly, but before it could say anything, Yuan drove his hand into its chest and ripped out its red crystal.

"W-What is the meaning of this?!" The demon roared.

"Now you don't have to ever worry about getting sealed again." Yuan said to it before crushing the crystal, killing the last demon.

After deactivating the Demon Sealing Zone, Yuan turned to look at the Manager and asked her, "Are you satisfied?"

The Manager narrowed her eyes at Yuan and spoke in a calm voice, "Prepare yourself. You'll be seeing the Lord tomorrow."

"What about my friend?"

"I have already made her a resident. She can move into the Dragon Spiral Mountain whenever."

"Thanks."

The Manager returned to the peak of the mountain shortly after while everyone else returned home.

"Aaaah! It's finally over!" Wang Ming shouted in an excited voice.

"Over? This is just the beginning. There are dozens if not hundreds of demons sealed around the world right now, and we're the only ones who can deal with them. I want all of you to be able to kill demons by yourself in the future." Yuan said.

"No way..." Wang Ming's jaw dropped.

"Having second thoughts about joining this faction?" Yuan smiled.

"Hell no!" He immediately shook his head.

"Good."

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Chapter 946 - The Lord's True Identity

Chapter 946 - The Lord's True Identity

"So he's finally killed the last demon, huh?" The Lord mumbled in a relieved voice after hearing the news from the Manager.

"Are you really going to reveal your true identity to him? I still don't think we can trust him. He's just a pervert who happens to have a knack for killing demons." The Manager said with a frown on her face.

"Do you really believe that, or are you just saying that out of frustration?" The Lord asked her.

The Manager gritted her teeth, refusing to answer.

"You can't be born with a 'knack' for killing demons. You need experience and technique. I don't know how or where he learned to kill demons, but we need him. The demons have been sealed for millions of years. It won't be long before they break out of their seal."

"Anyways, I have decided to tell him the truth about my identity, but I can continue to keep your identity a secret."

"Whatever." The Manager sighed.

That night, after washing their bodies, Chu Liuxiang and Yuan left the bathroom without getting dressed.

"Are you sure you want to do this? The Love Capsule's effect lasted for 2 hours for Meixiu, but it will last around ten hours for me. In fact, you can

take the Love Capsule by yourself."

"No!" Chu Liuxiang immediately refused.

"I want to experience what Meixiu experienced, so I want you to take the Love Capsule as well! So what if it lasts for ten hours? I will do it even if it lasts 24 hours!"

After listening to her stubborn and resolute words, Yuan no longer tried to convince her.

The two of them consumed the Love Capsule pill shortly after.

Chu Liuxiang's body immediately started burning with passion.

Yuan could feel the sword between his legs turning as hard as steel.

Seeing his body like this, Chu Liuxiang suddenly fell to her knees and started the action with her mouth.

Sometime later, they went to the bed and started the real action.

After an hour of intensive and passionate session, Yuan asked her, "How do you feel?"

"I feel like the night's just begun!" Chu Liuxiang said as she moved in a riding motion while sitting on top of Yuan's body.

Another hour later, Yuan asked, "Has the effect worn off yet?"

"You don't need to worry about me, darling. Just keep going until we're both satisfied." She said to him.

Although Yuan was hesitant, as he was worried about hurting her, he ended up agreeing to her reckless decision.

After another hour, when the effects finally disappeared, Chu Liuxiang decided to consume another Love Capsule.

"Meixiu only took one Love Capsule, you know." Yuan said to her.

"I know I'm cheating a little, but I was curious." She chuckled.

Thus, they continued to embrace each other for the rest of the night.

"The Love Capsule's effect seems to have strengthened for me. It lasted 12 hours this time." Yuan said at the end of their long session.

"How are you feeling?" He asked Chu Liuxiang a moment later, who was lying on the bed, her body still twitching a little.

"That was an amazing night we spent together, darling. We should do it more often..." She said in an exhausted manner.

"I don't think that is very healthy..."

"What are you talking about? You know, you'll eventually spend more time having sex than sleeping once you accept more women into your life, so you might as well get used to it now."

"I don't really plan on having more partners, though. I am satisfied with just you and Meixiu."

"Unfortunately, you cannot plan love, darling. I also have a feeling that our family will continue to grow bigger."

"Well..."

"By the way, don't you have to meet with the Lord today?" Chu Liuxiang suddenly interrupted.

"Huh?"

Yuan froze for a moment.

"Oh crap! I completely forgot about it!"

Chu Liuxiang smiled and said, "Just go. I'll clean up the room."

"Thank you!"

Yuan went into the bathroom and quickly washed his body before getting dressed and rushing downstairs.

When he arrived at the front of the building, he could see the Manager standing there with an angry expression on her face.

"Do you have any idea how long I have been waiting for you?! One hour and fifteen minutes!" The Manager shouted at him while tapping on her watch in an aggressive manner.

"Sorry, but I was busy with something. You know, you could've just knocked on my door. Why didn't you?"

The Manager's face twitched a little, and she spoke in a slightly shaky voice, "S-Shut up! I'll do as I please!"

There was no way that she could tell him the truth— that she'd gone to his room but didn't have the courage to disturb his time with Chu Liuxiang.

'This pervert is like a dog in heat! Did he really spend the entire night screwing that Chu girl?! To think he'd do such a thing right before meeting with the Lord! Unbelievable!' She cried inwardly.

"Anyways, we're already way behind schedule! Let's go!" The Manager turned around and began power walking towards the peak of the mountain.

Sometime later, Yuan approached the Lord's cave.

"You're almost two hours late. Did something happen?" The Lord asked him.

"Well... I was busy with something and lost track of time. Sorry." Yuan replied with an apologetic smile on his face.

"He was so busy mating with the Chu girl that he'd forgotten about the meeting." The Manager suddenly said out loud.

Yuan's eyebrows twitched after hearing such words, but he didn't respond to it since it was true.

The Lord cleared his throat and spoke, "A-Anyways, I express my utmost gratitude to you for dealing with the 11 demons, Yuan."

Yuan shook his head and said, "I don't need your gratitude. I would've done it even if you didn't ask for my help."

"Very well. Then it's my turn to uphold my end of the agreement. Since you have killed the demons, I will now tell you about my true identity and the truth about Cultivation Online." The Lord said.

A few moments later, Yuan could hear the sound of footsteps coming from the cave before him.

'So he's finally showing his true self, huh?' Yuan patiently waited for the Lord to come out of his cave.

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Chapter 947 - The Lord's True Identity (2)

Chapter 947 - The Lord's True Identity (2)

'Hm? These footsteps sound too heavy for a human.' Yuan quickly noticed this after hearing the Lord's footsteps.

A few moments later, the footsteps stopped, but the Lord hadn't shown himself yet.

"Having second thoughts?" Yuan asked him with a calm smile.

"No, I am just giving you some time to prepare yourself. My appearance... It might shock you."

Yuan chuckled, "Let me guess, you're super ugly? This explains why you're holed up in that cave."

"Insolence!" The Manager suddenly shouted.

"I'm just joking. Anyways, there's no need to wait for me. I already know your true identity, after all."

"Oh? You do?" The Lord sounded quite surprised.

"Yes. Well, not exactly, but I know that you're not human. You're a Divine Beast, right? I don't know your species, but you're definitely a Divine Beast."

"..."

After a moment of silence, the footsteps continued, and a large figure appeared from the cave.

"How did you find out? And how long have you known?"

The Lord asked as he came out of the cave for the first time in a very long time, revealing his massive figure.

Yuan looked at the Lord's figure with his divine sense.

The Lord was around 10 meters tall. His body resembled that of a tiger, and it was covered in a beautiful coat of thick, red fur, almost like a Tibetan mastiff.

"What are you, a tiger?" Yuan asked him in a calm voice.

"I belong to the Ancient Mastiff's bloodline. Specifically, I am a Blood Mastiff." The Lord said.

"Mastiff, so you're a dog?"

"How dare you compare the bloodline of the Blood Mastiff to a mere dog!" The Manager shouted at him again.

The Lord laughed, "I thought you'd be more nervous or surprised. How unfortunate."

Yuan shrugged, "I have met with plenty of Divine Beasts in Cultivation Online already. How do Blood Mastiffs compare to Phoenixes or Dragons?"

"Well, that depends on the grade of our bloodline and our race. Not all Phoenixes and Dragons are born equal. For example, there are over 10 different kinds of Phoenixes, and the Golden Phoenix ranks 4th amongst all Phoenixes. Meanwhile, Dragons have over 100 different bloodlines, and the Flood Dragon is ranked 94th."

"The Blood Mastiff, while they cannot compare to the most powerful Dragons and Phoenixes out there, we are stronger than most Phoenixes and Dragons."

"I see..." Yuan mumbled.

And he continued, "Anyway, I figured it out not long ago due to something Liya said."

"M-Me?!" The Manager exclaimed.

The Lord narrowed his eyes and spoke, "Let me guess... You figured it out when she said that she couldn't learn demon sealing techniques."

Yuan nodded, "That's right. All humans are capable of learning demon sealing techniques. The only beings that cannot learn them are magical beasts and Divine Beasts."

He turned to face Liya and asked her, "Are you also a Blood Mastiff?"

However, she refused to respond to him.

"You don't need to tell me if you don't want to. However, I am curious. If she can transform into a human and interact with other humans, why aren't you doing the same. Instead, you choose to stay up here." Yuan then asked.

The Lord sighed, "It's not that I don't want to transform into a human. I can't — at least not right now."

"Why not? What's preventing you from doing so?"

"I am currently maintaining a formation that requires immense spiritual energy. It's constantly absorbing my spiritual energy— so much so that I cannot even spare some to transform into a human. And before you ask, no, it's not the formation that conceals the peak of this mountain. In fact, this 'formation' is more of a 'seal' that's existing within my body."

"What does the formation do?"

"It keeps this world alive." The Lord said, dumbfounding him.

"Huh? What do you mean?"

"You see, there is a massive formation that surrounds this world. You cannot see it, but it's there. This formation is what's keeping this world from falling apart. If I deactivate the formation, this world will be destroyed. It is also my duty to keep this formation active at all times, and I have been doing this for millions of years."

Yuan was speechless. What the Lord told him was beyond even his wildest imaginations.

"You must be wondering why this world is on the verge of destruction." The Lord spoke after a moment of silence.

Yuan pondered and asked, "Does it have anything to do with Cultivation Online?"

"Yes, it does."

"Since you already know that Cultivation Online, which takes place in the Nine Heavens, exists out there, this will make explaining a lot easier."

"This world known as Earth used to be part of the Nine Heavens, but it was separated during a massive war that not only removed 'Earth' from the Nine Heavens, but also created the 'Nine Heavens' at the same time."

"I don't get it." Yuan tilted his head.

"Well, you see, the Nine Heavens wasn't always split into 9 different realms. The Nine Heavens used to be one place. This means the Lower Heaven and all of the other Heavens existed in the same plane, so you didn't need to ascend or descend. With that being said, since the world was so massive, the people made nine different continents, and each continent was called 'First Heaven', 'Second Heaven', 'Third Heaven', and so on..."

"In case you're wondering, the Nine Heavens used to be called the Divine Heaven."

"I see..." Yuan mumbled as he digested the information.

"Anyways, Earth couldn't be part of the new Nine Heavens because it was too small and had drifted too far away, and without the Nine Heavens' support, Earth could not support itself, hence why the formation is required to keep this world in one piece."

"I'm surprised you're able to support this world with that cultivation." Yuan said.

"My cultivation dropped to peak Spirit Emperor only because of the seal in my body. My real cultivation is actually far higher." The Lord sighed.

Yuan nodded, "I understand the situation of our world and the Nine Heavens, but what's the deal with Cultivation Online? What is its real purpose?"

"I'm getting there." The Lord said.

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Chapter 948 - The Truth About Cultivation Online

Chapter 948 - The Truth About Cultivation Online

"Before I tell you about the truth about Cultivation Online, let me ask you this... Do you know how it works? How you can visit the Nine Heavens through Cultivation Online?" The Lord asked.

Yuan pondered for a moment before speaking, "It obviously has something to do with the console we put on our head, but I have inspected it multiple times, even taking it apart. Despite that, I couldn't find anything special about it."

"I'm not surprised, since you don't have the means to see the formation."

"Formation? There is a formation in the console?"

"Yes, and it's actually two different formations, both fairly powerful formations called the Soul Transference Array and the Spirit Avatar Array."

"The Soul Transference Array transfers a part of your soul to the Nine Heavens— just enough so that your actual body doesn't become soulless and die, and the Spirit Avatar Array transforms your separated soul into an avatar— your character."

"This is why Cultivation Online feels so real— because it's a real world, and you're there as a soul."

Yuan frowned upon hearing this, "Our soul? Isn't that really bad? If one's soul is damaged even in the slightest, it could really mess up a person's life

and turn them braindead. If our character is our soul, doesn't that mean all damages inflicted on the character will also be inflicted on our soul?"

"Indeed, but you don't need to worry about that too much. While it's true that your character is made out of your soul, it's not entirely your soul. Unless you are hit by techniques specifically meant to damage one's soul, your soul won't get damaged."

"With that being said, if you die in Cultivation Online, there is a high chance that your actual soul will be damaged. This is why when players die, many of them lose their ability to cultivate— both in Cultivation Online and real life." The Lord explained.

"Of course, it's not guaranteed, hence why some people can still cultivate after they die. It is also the reason why even if you switch consoles, your character will remain the same."

"The heck?! How dare you tell me to not worry about it too much! That's super worrisome! Which genius decided to put our souls at risk while hiding the fact? And for what reason?" Yuan asked, feeling a little frustrated by the truth.

The Lord took a deep breath and spoke, "The Celestial Emperor."

"Hah? You mean the guy who rules over the Nine Heavens? Why on earth would he do such a thing?"

"Unfortunately, I do not know his intentions or goal. However, if I had to take a guess, I believe that he's trying to recruit talented people through Cultivation Online."

"How do I know that you're telling the truth?" Yuan suddenly said.

And he continued, "For all I know, you could be working for the Celestial Emperor. After all, how else would you know so much about Cultivation Online? I don't know what kind of person the Celestial Emperor is, nor do I know his purpose, but no matter his intentions, I do not agree with it. In fact, I would even say that I am against it."

"As much as I love Cultivation Online and am grateful to it, the Celestial Emperor is playing with our lives here, and he is doing so while keeping us in the dark about it. If you ask me, he's not a good guy."

"I can promise you that I am not working for the Celestial Emperor. However, I don't have any way to prove it to you, so you'll have to take my words for it."

"As someone who has lived in the Nine Heavens before it was split into nine different realms, it's only natural for me to know about the Nine Heavens and Earth. As for the truth about Cultivation Online, I knew it as soon as I saw the formations hidden within the consoles, and there is only one person in the Nine Heavens who is capable of achieving such a feat—the Celestial Emperor."

Yuan pondered for a moment before speaking, "Putting aside my trust for now, I have some questions."

"The people living within the Nine Heavens—the ones we call an NPC, how come they don't find anything wrong with us? We come back to life after we're killed, and we can log in and off at will, yet they all act as though it's completely natural."

The Lord sighed, "What I am about to say is only a theory, so I am not 100 percent on it, but I believe that the Celestial Emperor had placed a curse on these people, making it so that they don't find anything wrong with it."

"Curses like this exist?" Yuan raised an eyebrow.

"Yes. There are plenty of curses out there that can alter a person's personality, so something like this isn't too shocking if the Celestial Emperor is behind it all." The Lord nodded.

"With that being said, I don't think the curse is affecting everybody in the Nine Heavens. There are powerful Cultivators out there that surpass even the Celestial Emperor in terms of strength, so it's unlikely for these individuals to be cursed by him."

Hearing this information, Yuan remembered something, "The Great One... He knew that I didn't belong to the Nine Heavens, and he even knew my real name."

"You know the Great One?" The Lord looked at him with wide eyes.

"Not personally, but I have spoken with him once before, and I'd even accepted his Legacy."

"I see... Anyways, I have no doubt that the Great One isn't affected by the Celestial Emperor's curse. He's one of the most powerful beings in all of the Nine Heavens, after all." The Lord spoke in an admiring tone.

"Is there anything we can do to remove this curse... if it's even a curse?" Yuan then asked.

"I'm not sure, but you can try finding someone who is not affected by the curse and see if they can remove the curse." The Lord said.

"I see... That makes sense." Yuan nodded.

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Chapter 949 - Traveling to the Nine Heavens

Chapter 949 - Traveling to the Nine Heavens

"Now that you know about the connection between Earth and the Nine Heavens and the truth about Cultivation Online, let's talk about the Dragon Spiral Mountain." The Lord said.

"Have you ever thought about visiting the Nine Heavens?"

"Of course." Yuan immediately nodded his head.

"Well, the Dragon Spiral Mountain is actually a gateway to the Nine Heavens, meaning you can travel to the Nine Heavens."

"Really?!" Yuan shouted in excitement.

It has been a very long time since he was this excited about something.

"Yes, but it cannot be done now. The gateway to the Nine Heavens is a two-way portal, meaning that both gates must be activated in order for it to work. While I can activate the gate in this world, we will need someone to open the gate in the Nine Heavens. If you can do that, you will be able to travel to the Nine Heavens with your real body."

"Where can I find the gate in the Nine Heavens?!" Yuan eagerly asked.

"I'm not exactly sure myself, but it should be somewhere between the Fourth Heaven and the Seventh Heaven."

"That's three realms of possibilities! Are you telling me to search every nook and cranny of these realms?!" Yuan exclaimed.

"You won't spend that much effort on looking because the name of the gate in the Nine Heavens is the same as the one in this world— Dragon Spiral Mountain. Ask the right people and you will find it right away."

"I see..."

"By the way, what will happen if I travel to the Nine Heavens with my real body? What will happen to my character?"

"Nothing. Your character will remain active even if you go there with your real body. In fact, that essentially means you will have two bodies in that world— one made of flesh and one made of your soul."

"Oh, I should've mentioned this before when we were on the subject, but when you log off Cultivation Online, your soul doesn't return to you. Your character just loses its physical form and returns to being a 'soul', which is invisible to one's eyes."

"Huh? Does that mean my soul isn't in one piece even now?" Yuan quickly asked.

"Indeed. Your current body contains only about 10 percent of your soul, and the other 90 percent is currently in the Nine Heavens where you last logged off."

"No fucking way... Is that why I find it much harder to learn techniques in this world? Because I only have 10 percent of my soul?"

"That is correct."

"My impressions of this Celestial Emperor is decreasing with every passing moment..." Yuan sighed.

"Hmm? Wait. Is this also why despite cultivating in Cultivation Online, it doesn't affect our real body? What will happen if I regain all of my soul? Will I gain all of the cultivation it has gathered?" He then asked.

"Indeed. If you reabsorb your soul, you will gain everything it has learned and acquired, and this includes its cultivation and skills." The Lord confirmed.

"Then how come some of the treasures affect our real body?"

"Treasures affect one's soul differently. Even if the soul is separated, as long as you nourish one part of the soul, the other part will also receive the benefits. Don't ask me how it works. It just does."

"Then I want to ask about the gate. How do I activate it?" Yuan asked a moment later.

"The gate is actually a formation— a Level 7 formation. If you want to activate it, you'll need to become a Level 7 Array Master." The Lord said.

"Level 7..."

"Once you're capable of activating Level 7 Arrays and Formations, I will teach you how to activate the gate."

"Sounds good." Yuan nodded.

"Any more questions?"

"Of course. I still have tons. However, the one I want answers to the most right now would be this one— You mentioned that our souls will not be harmed unless our character dies or it suffers a technique meant for the soul. I want you to elaborate on that."

The Lord nodded and spoke, "There are techniques out there that directly inflicts damage on one's soul. Such techniques are incredibly rare and valuable— perhaps the rarest kind of technique out there. However, they exist, and if you're struck by such an attack, it could shatter your soul, and 90 percent of your soul will disappear."

Yuan swallowed nervously.

"Is there any way to combat these techniques?"

The Lord shook his head and sighed, "Unfortunately, the only way to defend against techniques that damage one's soul is to have a soul that's strong enough to endure the attack, and in order to strengthen your soul, you must practice soul tempering techniques, but such techniques are as rare as soul attacking techniques."

"That would be the stat 'Soul Strength' in Cultivation Online, correct?" Yuan asked, as he remembers hearing about them from Xiao Hua.

"Indeed. There are only two ways to improve your Soul Strength— by cultivating soul tempering techniques or by consuming treasures."

Yuan turned silent for a moment before speaking, "Then how come my Soul Strength increases alongside my cultivation? I have never cultivated any soul tempering techniques, nor do I recall consuming any treasures with such effect."

"What?! Is that true?! That your Soul Strength increases when you increase your cultivation?!" The Lord appeared to be greatly shocked after hearing his words.

"Yes, it's true."

The Lord's eyes flickered with countless emotions.

"D-Do you happen to know your bloodline?" He suddenly asked.

Yuan nodded, "It's called the Immortal Monarch Bloodline. Do you know of it?"

"Immortal Monarch Bloodline!" The Lord's legs nearly gave out on him after hearing this familiar name.

Even the Manager appeared to be quite shocked by it.

"So you do know something about it. This is great. I know nothing about my bloodline, so tell me everything you know!" Yuan said with a smile on his face, his excitement growing once again.

'The Immortal Monarch... To think I'd meet his descendant here... If this isn't fate...' The Lord sighed inwardly.

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Chapter 950 - Immortal Monarch

Chapter 950 - Immortal Monarch

After coming out of his daze, the Lord took a long and deep breath before speaking, "The Immortal Monarch is a prominent figure from after the Primordial Era. He has another nickname, but I will get to that later."

"First, you should probably learn more about the Nine Heavens and its history."

"The Primordial Era is the first known era. It's what some people call the 'beginning of time', as this is the furthest history goes."

"The Primordial Era lasted for countless millions of years. During this time, many legends were created."

"However, towards the end of the Primordial Era, a massive war between the first Celestial Emperor and the cultivators living in that world occurred. It was known as the Heavenly War of Immortals and Gods. I won't get into the details since it's really long and has nothing to do with our topic, but many powerful figures had died after that war."

"A few thousand years later, the Primordial Era ended when the first known demon 'Red Tyrant' suddenly showed up in the Divine Heaven. Because of the Heavenly War that resulted in the deaths of countless experts, the human race was quickly overwhelmed by the demons, thus the beginning of a new era—the Demoniac Era."

"The demons ruled the Divine Heavens for millions of years until the Divine Paragon appeared. After sealing the Demoniac Realm and defeating most of the demons out there, the Demoniac Era came to an end."

Yuan digested all of this information with a serious face.

'I see... Primordial Era and the Demonic Era... There's still so much I don't know even though I have the Divine Paragon's memories...'

The Lord continued after allowing Yuan some time to breathe.

"After the Demonic Era is an era known as the Immortal Monarch's Era, where a single person ruled."

"However, even though I say that he'd dominated the Nine Heavens, it wasn't anything official. Nobody knows the Immortal Monarch's background or where he came from, but he was so immensely powerful that not even the Celestial Emperor of that era could control him."

"With that being said, it was not his strength that truly shocked the world—it was his connections— his companions."

"The Immortal Monarch, also known as the Monarch of Beasts, was the first person in history to make Divine Beasts willingly obey him."

"What...?" Yuan was dumbfounded after hearing this information.

"Before the Immortal Monarch's Era, Divine Beasts did not communicate with humans, and to human cultivators, Divine Beasts were superior beings that lived in a different world."

"Humans revered Divine Beasts and treated them like Gods, so the idea of a Divine Beast lowering its head and serving a human was an unthinkable thing back then."

"However, the Immortal Monarch defied all logic and created history by becoming the first human to receive the Divine Beasts' support."

"As a result of this, the Immortal Monarch also became the most powerful Beast Tamer in the Nine Heavens. He was an untouchable figure that had many powerful Divine Beasts by his side."

After hearing this information about his bloodline, many things started making sense to Yuan.

The reason Feng Yuxiang and Lan Yingying found his blood delicious is most likely due to his bloodline that had many connections with Divine Beasts.

"If you don't mind me asking... May I have a drop of your blood for confirmation?" The Lord suddenly asked him.

"Sure." Yuan didn't refuse, as he wanted to see the Lord's reaction.

"W-What?! You're going to drink a human's blood?! That's insane!" The Manager suddenly shouted.

"Silence!" The Lord roared.

"If what he said is true, then he's not just any ordinary human! He's related to the Immortal Monarch, who had the support of the Nine Ancient Beasts! Do you have any idea what this means?!"

"What's the Nine Ancient Beasts?" Yuan asked out of curiosity.

"The Nine Ancient Beasts refers to the most powerful and ancient Divine Beasts in the Nine Heavens. They're said to be the first Divine Beasts to ever exist, so they're basically the ancestors of all Divine Beasts."

"I see... Anyway, here's my blood."

Yuan collected a single drop of his blood and gave it to the Lord.

The Lord's body visibly trembled afterward.

"T-This is...! This is, without doubt, the Immortal Monarch's Bloodline! Only the Immortal Monarch's Bloodline can taste unique to us Divine Beasts!" The Lord exclaimed.

"The blood of normal humans tastes like muddy water to us Divine Beast, but the Immortal Monarch is different. His blood tastes would taste more

delicious than even the most delicious thing we have ever eaten, and that is exactly what your blood tasted like."

"Is that so..."

Yuan noticed the weird expression on the Manager's face and turned to look at her with a smile on his face.

"Liya, do you also want to taste my blood? I can tell that you're curious." He asked her.

"There's no way that I would want to taste the blood of a human! I don't care if you have the Immortal Monarch's Bloodline— I won't accept you—a human!" The Manager responded with gritted teeth.

Yuan raised his eyebrows and turned to ask the Lord, "Did something happen with her? Her hate for humans doesn't appear to be natural."

"M-Mind your own business!" The Manager shouted.

The Lord shook his head and said, "I'm afraid that I do not have the right to tell her story. If you truly wish to know, you must ask her."

"Don't even think about it! Because I won't tell you no matter what!" The Manager continued.

"Don't worry, I won't force you. You can tell me when you're ready." Yuan said with a smile.

'Damn, he's so irritating! Why does he have to make it sound like I am going to tell him in the future?! And he sounds so confident about it!' The Manager cried inwardly.

"I apologize for her, Young Master Yuan." The Lord said a moment later.

"Huh? What did you just call me?" Yuan doubted his hearing just now.

Chapter 951 - Immortal Monarch's Descendant

Chapter 951 - Immortal Monarch's Descendant

"Since it's confirmed that you have the Immortal Monarch's Bloodline, I must address you properly. It's only natural, as you're the Immortal Monarch's descendant." The Lord said.

"Just continue calling me Yuan. I don't like it when people suddenly change the way they address me. It feels awkward."

"I understand, Yuan." The Lord nodded.

"Anyways, I still have more questions."

"Ask away."

"Why are you responsible for the seal on Earth? Who decided that?"

"It was my decision and idea to accept the seal." The Lord said.

"Why? Your strength is sealed, and your energy is constantly being absorbed by the seal. Why would you agree to what is essentially constant torture?"

The Lord smiled and said, "Believe it or not, I do it because I love humans."

"Huh? What kind of nonsense is that?"

"I know, you probably think it's stupid. I am well aware of how cringe and typical my reasoning is, but it's the truth. Furthermore, I was born on Earth

— at least before it got its name. Earth was a small part of First Heaven before, and it was my hometown."

Yuan sighed, "Well, I'm not going to make fun of your decision even though I find it ridiculous, so I'm going to go ahead and move to the next question."

"Since there are two Divine Beasts here, could there be other Divine Beasts hidden in this world? What about magical beasts? Where did they go? And how did the existence of cultivation disappear for the majority of the world?"

"I'm not sure if there are other Divine Beasts out there since it's been countless years since I have left this place, but it's not impossible. As for the magical beasts... They were all hunted to extinction. Normally, more magical beasts would be born after some time, but due to the lack of spiritual energy in this world and its small size, such a thing did not happen."

"Now onto why the majority of this world forgot about cultivation... Honestly, I don't know how it happened. I went into a deep slumber shortly after I took the seal into my body, and when I woke up, it was as though the entire world had forgotten about cultivation."

"With that being said, the people living on Earth before it was separated from the Nine Heavens were mostly mortals, so that could be a cause."

"Perhaps the people of this world decided to give up on cultivation altogether and started focusing on technology instead. Who knows."

"After all, if you think about it, even a somewhat powerful cultivation can remove mountains with ease, and considering the size of this world, it would be for the best if people stopped cultivation."

"Let's take you for example, Yuan. At your current level, you are more than capable of destroying this world, and you're only a Spirit Grandmaster. However, these are all just speculations."

"I see..." Yuan mumbled.

After pondering for sometime, he spoke, "All right, I will leave things here for now. There is a lot of new information that I need to think about and digest. When I'm ready to talk again, I will come back with more questions."

"Very well. We'll be here whenever you need us." The Lord said.

"Liya, escort him back, and do not be disrespectful to him." The Lord turned to her and said.

"Oh! One more thing. Do you mind if I tell my friends about the stuff I learned today?" Yuan suddenly asked.

"If you want. Just try not to spread it too much. It might cause the entire world to panic."

"All right."

Yuan left the peak of the mountain shortly after.

"You don't need to follow me all the way. I can get back by myself." Yuan said to the Manager after they left the formation.

"Say no more." The Manager turned around and started walking back to the peak of the mountain without any hesitation.

After returning to the peak of the mountain, the Manager walked straight to the cave and spoke in a frustrated voice, "Why did you lower yourself to him? That wasn't part of the agreement!"

"He's the Immortal Monarch's descendant. It's only natural for Divine Beasts to lower their heads before him."

"That's bullshit! He's not the Immortal Monarch! He's just a descendant!"

"Descendant or not, as long as he has the bloodline, we are obligated to respect him. This is the will of our ancestors— the will of the Nine Ancient Beasts."

"In fact, let me give you a suggestion, Liya. Go serve him. It will benefit you greatly."

"What?! You want me to serve that pervert?! Are you insane? I won't do such a thing even if it's the last thing I do!" She immediately refused.

"Those that carry the Immortal Monarch's Bloodline are destined to do great things. There are even Divine Beasts out there that dream of being beside someone with that bloodline. You should really take advantage of your situation and create a connection with him before he inevitably travels to the Nine Heavens with his real body."

"You sound like you want to be his servant. Why don't you do it then?"

The Lord shook his head, "I would be lying if I say that I don't want to serve him, but I am not worthy to be by his side."

"You, on the other hand..."

"Don't even think about it. I will never serve a human!"

"What a pity. His blood is really tasty, you know? If you become his servant, you might be able to drink his blood very often. Legend also has it that if a Divine Beast drinks enough of the Immortal Monarch's blood, they can 'evolve', becoming more powerful than ever."

The Manager swallowed nervously after hearing such words, but she quickly shook the idea away.

"I don't care if he's the Immortal Monarch's descendant— even if he's the Immortal Monarch himself, I will not serve him! I hate humans! And I will never forgive them for their crimes!" After saying such words, the Manager turned around and disappeared from the scene.

Chapter 952 - On the Verge of Destruction

Chapter 952 - On the Verge of Destruction

After returning home, Yuan gathered everyone in the faction to let them know the truth about Cultivation Online.

"What I am about to say is very shocking, and you might even not believe me, but trust me, it's real."

"First and foremost, Cultivation Online— the Nine Heavens is real, and our world used to be part of it. The Nine Heavens was known as Divine Heaven before, but something happened, causing it to split into many different pieces."

"The nine largest parts of Divine Heaven became known as the Nine Heavens."

"Earth was too small and had drifted too far away to join the Nine Heavens, so we became our own world."

"However, because of the separation, Earth isn't in a good condition. Hell, you can even say that it's on the verge of destruction."

"What?!" Everyone there exclaimed in a shocked voice.

"Yes, even now, the world is on the verge of collapsing on itself. The only reason it's not is because of the Lord— the Lord of the Dragon Spiral Mountain."

"He's keeping this world safe with a powerful formation that surrounds this world. Oh, you should know that the Lord is not human. He's actually a Divine Beast."

"W-Wait, wait, wait! Let me digest a little before you continue." Wang Ming suddenly said.

"So let me get this straight. This world used to exist in the Nine Heavens before it got split into many parts, and it's now on the verge of destruction. However, thanks to the Lord of the Dragon Spiral Mountain, who is not human, the world is safe. Is that it?"

"Yes, that's right." Yuan calmly nodded.

"Holy shit... I can't believe it... I mean, I believe you, but I am having trouble believing it..."

"How long do you think the Lord will continue protecting this world?" Shi Lang suddenly asked.

"If he suddenly decides to give up, or he can no longer support this world, won't that mean the end of the world for us?"

"According to him, he's been protecting this world ever since Earth was separated from the Nine Heavens. That's at least a few million years." Yuan said.

And he continued, "I don't know how long he can continue protecting us, but I doubt it will be forever. I will ask him the next time we meet."

"Is there anything we can do? I don't like the feeling of entrusting the entire human race to one person. Like Shi Lang had mentioned, this Lord could suddenly give up and destroy the world."

Yuan pondered for a moment before speaking, "I'm just speculating, but perhaps the seal can be passed onto another person. If I become strong enough, I might be able to bear this seal and keep this world safe. With that

being said, I will need to seriously increase my cultivation before that can happen."

"There's another thing we can do... We can all move to the Nine Heavens and live there instead. I was going to mention this next, but we can travel to the Nine Heavens from here. The Dragon Spiral Mountain is a gateway to the Nine Heavens, but we need to activate the gate from both sides before we can travel there."

"Basically, we will be abandoning Earth, right?" Wang Bingbing said.

"Basically." Yuan nodded.

"Honestly, there's nothing we can do right but trust the Lord that he will not destroy the world. In the meantime, I will try to see if there is anything I can do to prevent this world from getting destroyed in the future."

Sometime later, Yuan continued their conversation.

"Let's talk about Cultivation Online now. The console that we've all been using has two different formations hidden within. The Soul Transference Array and the Soul Avatar Array."

"Essentially, these arrays transfer a part of our soul to the Nine Heavens, and using our soul, it creates our character, allowing us to visit the Nine Heavens without actually going there."

"However, there's the thing. Because our character is our soul, any damages done to our character can actually harm our real bodies. I hope none of you have died in Cultivation Online."

Everyone there exchanged shocked looks with each other.

"I haven't died yet."

"Me neither."

Yuan sighed in relief after hearing that nobody in the faction has died in Cultivation Online.

"Now that we all know our characters are created using our souls, we should be extra careful with ourselves and try to not get hurt as much as possible, just in case."

Yuan turned to face Li Jinxi and continued, "Especially you, Jinxi. Out of everyone here, I worry about you the most. You're the type to go overboard and get too excited very quickly."

"Getting your soul damaged is nothing like hurting your physical body. If your soul is damaged, you could easily become braindead."

Everyone there trembled after hearing such words.

"Now that you mention it... There are rumors of players who have suddenly become brain dead after dying too many times in Cultivation Online." Wu Zao suddenly said.

"I will verify that information later."

"Hey, if it's actually this dangerous to play Cultivation Online, shouldn't we warn the others and make this information public?" Xi Murong suddenly asked.

"I don't think anyone would believe us even if we tried to warn them..." Wang Bingbing sighed.

"Right? They'll probably think we're crazy or something." Chu Liuxiang agreed.

"We won't say anything to the public for now. Cultivation Online was created by the Celestial Emperor, who is the ruler of the Nine Heavens, and not even the Lord knows his purpose for creating Cultivation Online. Also, the Celestial Emperor willingly put all of our lives at risk for his own goals. I don't care what his intentions are, but he's playing with our lives, nor does he seem to care about the consequences." Yuan said with gritted teeth.

"And I will not let anyone play with our lives— not even if he's the Celestial Emperor!"

Everyone there swallowed nervously after hearing his words that sounded like a declaration of war to the Celestial Emperor.

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Chapter 953 - Leaving the Dragon Spiral Mountain

Chapter 953 - Leaving the Dragon Spiral Mountain

"Now that you all know the truth, I am going to tell you my plans." Yuan spoke again after letting the others some time to digest the information.

"I will first find the Dragon Spiral Mountain within the Nine Heavens and activate it. Then I will travel to the Nine Heavens and reabsorb my soul. That way, I will be at my full potential."

"I'm not exactly sure what I am going to do afterward, but I will think of something by then— hopefully."

"Oh yeah, I should also warn you about techniques that can damage your soul. Since your character is created from your soul, it wouldn't be wise to be struck by such a fatal attack. Therefore, avoid them at all costs."

Sometime later, Yuan said to them, "Anyways, now that is out of the way, I have a small announcement to make."

"My sister's birthday is coming up soon, and I plan on visiting her, so I won't be here for a few days starting tomorrow. Any questions?"

Chu Liuxiang immediately raised her hand and said, "I wanted to ask you this sooner, but can I go with you? I want to meet Yu Rou in person this time."

"I don't mind." Yuan nodded.

"Thank you!"

Everyone returned to their own rooms to further think about the information Yuan revealed shortly after.

That night, Yuan went to spend the night with Meixiu.

"You're not going to use the Love Capsules this time?" Yuan asked her as they prepared for their love session.

"No... I was only curious about it last time. Honestly, it doesn't feel right—consuming medicine to enhance my performance. I don't want to rely on medicine to keep up with you. However, I will admit that it was a fun time. I have never been pushed so far past my limit."

Yuan smiled and said, "I also don't want to rely on those Love Capsules. Chu Liuxiang said that I will eventually find more partners, and when that happens, I will need the stamina to love them as well. Even though a single Love Capsule can keep me going for half a day, I don't like the feeling of being out of control, so I will also refrain from using them in the future and use my own strength to satisfy you."

"Yuan..."

Meixiu made her advancement and kissed Yuan on the lips.

However, right as things started getting intense, Meixiu's cell phone started ringing.

"This is..." Meixiu swallowed nervously after seeing the name of the caller.

"Who could be calling so late into the night?" Yuan asked her as he stopped moving his body.

"I-It's Yu Rou..." Meixiu said.

"Should I answer it?"

"Go ahead." Yuan nodded as he pulled his sword out of Meixiu's cave before laying on the bed beside her.

Meixiu took a deep breath before accepting the call.

"Hello! Meixiu, is this a good time?" Yu Rou's voice was filled with enthusiasm.

"Yes, I can speak now." Meixiu said.

"Great! Do you know what my brother is doing right now? I was hoping to speak with him."

Meixiu turned to look at Yuan, who quickly shook his head.

"Sorry, but Yuan is actually out of the house now..."

"Eh? Isn't it nighttime over there? What is he doing out so late?"

"He had to speak with the Lord of the Dragon Spiral Mountain. It seemed very important." Meixiu didn't think she'd have to lie to Yu Rou in such a manner, and she felt like someone who was lying her way out of being caught cheating.

"Haaa... I haven't been able to hear Brother's voice in so long. I think this is the longest I have ever gone without seeing him or hearing his voice!"

"What did you want to speak with Yuan about? I can tell him for you when he returns."

Yu Rou remained silent for a good moment before finally speaking, "It's nothing too important. I just wanted to see if we can schedule a video call in a few days. It's my birthday, after all."

"Do you think my brother even remembers my birthday?" Yu Rou then asked.

"Of course! Yuan won't forget something so important!"

"Really? I don't know... It's just been so long... I'm afraid that he's forgotten about me now that he's truly free."

"Don't be silly, Yu Rou. You're his precious little sister. He will never forget about you." Meixiu reassured her.

"Then let's put that to the test. Don't tell my brother about this conversation, and don't remind him about my birthday. If he truly remembers, he will be the one contacting me instead."

"Okay, I won't say anything to Yuan. I promise."

"Thank you, Meixiu. It's almost time for my morning training, so I leave now. I will call you again later to listen to your stories!"

"See you later, Yu Rou."

After closing the phone, Meixiu turned to look at Yuan and said,
"Technically, you overheard our conversation, so I didn't tell you again."

Yuan showed a bittersweet smile and said, "That silly girl is worried that I might have forgotten about her? My one and only sister? Not going to lie, I feel a little sad."

"And in order to make sure that she will never have such worries again, I will give her the best birthday present ever!"

"What do you have in mind?" Meixiu asked out of curiosity.

"I will tell you when we're on the plane tomorrow."

The two of them resumed their business with each other shortly after.

The following morning, Yuan, Meixiu, and Chu Liuxiang left the Dragon Spiral Mountain in a car and made their way to the airport.

On their way to the airport, Yuan made sure to tell Chu Liuxiang that his relationship with them must be kept a secret.

"I don't mind keeping our relationship a secret, but if she asks me, I will tell her that I love you— not that she doesn't know that already." Chu Liuxiang chuckled.

Sometime later, the three of them boarded the airplane and started flying towards Yu Rou's location.

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Chapter 954 - Player Yuan's Face

Chapter 954 - Player Yuan's Face

"So, what are your plans? What do you plan on giving Yu Rou for her birthday?" Meixiu asked Yuan shortly after the plane took off.

"Well, first of all, I need to meet with White Lotus and schedule my visit to their faction. As for Yu Rou's birthday present, I am going to give her a concert." Yuan said.

"A concert? Like the one you gave before she left?" Meixiu raised her eyebrows.

"You cannot call that a concert! I meant a real concert! And it will not be under my alias, Tian Yang. I will be going as 'Yu Tian'."

Meixiu's jaw dropped slightly upon hearing his words.

"I am done hiding. I will let the world know that I have returned. I'm sure this will make Yu Rou happier than any physical gift I can buy her."

"What about the Yu Family? They will definitely try to force you to return." Chu Liuxiang asked.

"What about them? I am no longer in the family, and they even disowned me." Yuan said.

"That might not be the case." Chu Liuxiang shook her head, and she continued, "Even though they have disowned you, you are still legally 'Yu Tian' and part of the Yu Family. Furthermore, I'm sure that you'd signed some contracts with the Yu Family when you were still young and active, which will most likely legally bind you to their company."

"Lulu is right, Yuan." Meixiu said.

"You probably don't remember this, but your parents made you sign this contract that legally binds you to their company... forever. And unlike my mother, you cannot buy your way out of the contract. The only way to leave is if the Yu Family willingly destroys the contract."

"What the hell? That sounds illegal. And wouldn't I be too young to sign contracts?" Yuan said.

"Not if they altered the contract without your knowledge and made it look like you signed it at a legal age. It's a common trick in the industry." Chu Liuxiang said.

Yuan sighed, "I'm not surprised. However, that won't stop my return. They can try whatever they want, but I am now strong enough to fight back. If they try anything funny, I will destroy the entire Yu Family."

"What about you, Meixiu? Do you plan on giving anything to Yu Rou?"

"Well... I have been thinking about it, but I don't know what to give her. I have never given her a birthday gift since it wasn't appropriate for me, her servant, to do so."

"I think she will be happy with anything you give her. It's the thought that truly counts."

"What about you?" Meixiu suddenly turned to Chu Liuxiang and asked her.

"Unfortunately, I don't know Yu Rou enough to buy something. Of course, I could just buy something random, like buying gifts for a stranger I have never met, but that doesn't sit right with me, so I am going to try and understand Yu Rou as much as I can so that I can buy something worthy for her next year!"

Sometime later, Meixiu asked, "By the way, how are you going to start a concert? We only have three days until Yu Rou's birthday, two and half if you consider how long it will take us to get there."

"It's not going to be an official concert. I'm just going to set up a public concert and do it there. I've already asked the Cultivators' Association to help me with the setup. They happily agreed."

"I see..."

Many hours later at the Eternal Lotuses' headquarters.

"Miss Bai, your ride is prepared. We can leave whenever. Player Yuan's plane should arrive in two hours." Her Manager notified her.

"I understand. We'll leave in five minutes."

"Understood."

Sometime later, White Lotus secretly left the headquarters with her manager to meet with Yuan.

About half an hour later, they arrived at the most luxurious and famous hotel in the entire entire— White Lotus.

Indeed, it was named after White Lotus by her family, who owned the hotel.

"Welcome, Young Lady."

The Manager of the hotel personally greeted her at the front door.

"Are the preparations ready?" She asked him.

"Yes. The entire balcony has been reserved for the Young Lady, and our best chefs are all here today."

"Good." White Lotus nodded.

"The Young Lady sure is dressed elegantly today. Just who is she meeting today?" The hotel manager wondered inwardly as he gazed upon White Lotus' beautiful appearance that attracted the attention of everyone there.

"How long until 'he' arrives?" White Lotus asked her Manager.

"The plane will land in 30 minutes. He should arrive approximately in 1 hour and 20 minutes."

"And his ride?"

"Already at the airport waiting for his arrival."

"I'm going to double check my appearance. You should also go to the airport to make sure his arrival is as smooth as possible." White Lotus said before leaving.

"I understand."

'I haven't seen her this motivated and serious in such a long time. It's almost like she's meeting with her crush... Even though she says that she's not nervous, anyone can tell that's a lie...' The manager couldn't help but smile inwardly.

Half an hour later, Yuan's plane landed in the airport.

After leaving the airplane, Yuan immediately noticed three conspicuous beautiful women standing at his terminal, and they were dressed in a black suit, almost like they were from the secret service.

Yuan immediately approached these three women after seeing the sign one of them was holding that had a single word on it, 'Birthday'.

"Are you with White Lotus?" Yuan asked them.

"You must be Player Yuan. It's a pleasure to finally meet you. I am White Lotus' personal manager, Jasmine. These two behind me will be your bodyguard for today."

'So this is what the famous Player Yuan looks like...'

These three ladies thought to themselves as they stared at Yuan's handsome face. They expected him to be wearing a mask to protect his identity like in Cultivation Online, but the only thing he was wearing on his face was a pair of sunglasses, which was out of their expectations.

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Chapter 955 - Meeting White Lotus in Person

Chapter 955 - Meeting White Lotus in Person

"Just call me Yuan." He said to the three ladies.

"By the way, these are my friends, Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang. They will be visiting my sister as well."

"I understand." Jasmine nodded calmly.

However, she was inwardly shocked by Yuan's appearance.

'Our investigations on Yu Rou's only brother, Yu Tian, said that he had suffered an unknown illness when he was at a very young age, becoming a cripple that couldn't even leave the bed without someone helping him. But he looks perfectly healthy to me...'

"Our car is outside. We'll bring you to White Lotus," she said a moment later.

Yuan and the others followed these ladies outside to their limousine.

Yuan's group and Jasmine and one of the bodyguards sat in the back while the second bodyguard drove the limousine.

"If you have any questions, please don't hesitate to ask me." Jasmine said to them.

"Sure."

However, the ride to the hotel where White Lotus was waiting was much more quiet than Jasmine had anticipated.

Neither Yuan nor the other two spoke a single word for the entire trip, which made Jasmine and the bodyguards quite nervous, as they were worried that something was troubling them.

Jasmine wanted to start a conversation with Yuan multiple times, but she was worried that she might bother them by doing so.

In the end, she decided to remain silent and spent the entire trip staring at Yuan's face, who was silently staring in front of him.

Although it looked like Yuan had turned into a stone statue, he was actually enjoying the view of the city with his Divine Sense.

As for Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang, they had their eyes closed, almost as though they were trying to sleep.

Truth was, they had nothing to say, so they just closed their eyes and patiently waited for them to arrive at their destination.

About twenty minutes later, the limousine came to a complete stop, and Jasmine spoke, "We have arrived at our destination, Yuan."

"This hotel..." Yuan noticed the name of this hotel to be the same as White Lotus, and this made him curious.

"This is the White Lotus Hotel. It's the highest rated and most luxurious hotel in the entire city. The hotel is also owned by the Bai Family. In case you didn't know already, White Lotus' real name is Bai Lianhua. As for why the hotel is named after White Lotus, her parents were the one who came up with this idea."

The moment Yuan stepped out of the car, he noticed a beautiful woman with a familiar face approaching their direction, her silky white hair flowing behind her back like a cape.

He turned to greet her with a gentle smile on his face, "Hello, White Lotus. Thank you for coming all the way out here for us."

"It's my pleasure, Yuan. How was your journey here? I hope it was comfortable." White Lotus returned his smile with one of her own, but she was inwardly shocked for the same reason that shocked Jasmine.

'Did something go wrong with our intel? He looks nothing like a cripple!' She cried inwardly.

"She's quite the woman, don't you think so?" Chu Liuxiang whispered to Meixiu.

She nodded her head and said, "Quite bold with her appearance, too."

White Lotus was wearing a white dress that complimented her silky hair and tall figure perfectly, but it was also quite revealing, especially the area around her chest that barely covered her bare breasts.

"She's definitely trying to seduce Yuan with her big boobs. I must admit, they're a size or two bigger than ours." Chu Liuxiang whispered to Meixiu, who was speechless.

"Let me introduce you to my friends. This is Meixiu, who used to work for my sister, and this is Chu Liuxiang, my childhood friend. They're also here to celebrate Yu Rou's birthday." Yuan calmly introduced his companions to White Lotus.

White Lotus looked at Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang and smiled, "Nice to meet you."

'He's visiting his sister on her birthday with two beautiful women by his side? What is their relationship with him?' She wondered inwardly.

Yuan and the others followed White Lotus into the hotel shortly after while the workers there handled their luggage.

"Do you want to visit your rooms now? I'm sure you're tired after your long flight." White Lotus asked them.

"We're fine. We had plenty of sleep on the plane." Yuan said.

"With that being said, I am quite hungry."

"Then let's head to the restaurant first."

Sometime later, they arrived at the roof of the hotel, where they could see the majority of the city without any obstruction.

"Wow, what beautiful scenery." Chu Liuxiang said out loud.

"I'm glad you like it."

White Lotus led them to the only table there.

Once they were all seated, White Lotus said, "Order anything you want and don't worry about the bill."

Yuan looked at the menu that was much smaller than what he was used to.

Because he has never eaten at an expensive restaurant, he did not know that most luxurious restaurants like this offer a smaller menu to keep the food quality higher.

"I will have everything on the menu." Yuan said after a glance at the menu.

"E-Everything?" White Lotus and the waiter were taken aback by his words.

"Don't worry, I won't waste any food." Yuan smiled at them.

Sometime later, once all of their orders were taken, the waiter rushed to the kitchen and told the chefs to cook everything on the menu and some more.

"What? I was told that we would only be serving very few guests, not several families!" The chefs were baffled by the news.

Despite their shock, the chefs immediately began their work, causing the temperature in the kitchen to rise very quickly.

While they waited, White Lotus started the conversation by saying to Yuan, "By the way, those sunglasses look really good on you."

"Thank you. But I am not wearing these for fashion. To tell you the truth, I am actually blind." Yuan said with a smile.

"Blind?" White Lotus was at loss for words.

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Chapter 956 - Who Are You Trying to Seduce?!

Chapter 956 - Who Are You Trying to Seduce?!

'How can he be blind? He's walking around just fine without any support...'
White Lotus wondered to herself after hearing Yuan's seemingly outrageous claim.

Yuan smiled and removed his sunglasses, revealing to her his silver eyes.

White Lotus covered her mouth in shock and asked in a trembling voice,
"I'm sorry... But how...?"

"Once you reach Spirit Master, you will be able to use something called Divine Sense, which will allow you to see your surroundings without needing to use your actual eyes. It's a very convenient skill, and you can even see things that you normally wouldn't be able to see with your bare eyes."

"Y-You're already a Spirit Master?" White Lotus was shocked once again.

'I am still only at the 3rd level of Spirit Warrior, yet he's already a Spirit Master?! How does he progress so fast?'

"Actually, I am a Spirit Grandmaster right now." Yuan said.

"What?!" White Lotus stood up from shock and shouted, startling them.

"E-Excuse me..." White Lotus quickly realized her mistake and sat back down with her face slightly rosy.

'If I recall correctly, even the 2nd strongest player is only a peak Spirit Master! If we don't include the person himself, this guy has managed to surpass the strongest cultivator in Cultivation Online in the real world! This achievement is nothing short of absurd!' She cried inwardly.

It was at this moment that White Lotus realized just how much she and the rest of the world were underestimating him.

'I must rope him into my Bai Family at all cost! Even if he doesn't join us, I want to maintain a good relationship with him! Fortunately for us, his younger sister is a member of our faction. This gives us a massive advantage over the others!'

White Lotus was getting more nervous with every passing moment, and the mission her family assigned her resounded louder and clearer.

"Player Yuan must join our Bai Family! You must do whatever you can to win him over, even if you have to use your own body!"

"Are you okay? You don't seem very well." Yuan suddenly asked her after noticing her pale complexion.

"E-Eh? Sorry, I was just thinking about some things. I am fine." White Lotus immediately fixed her expression and even put a charming smile on her face.

"Anyways, let's talk about your purpose here— to surprise Yu Rou. I already have everything planned to make sure your surprise visit is a success!"

"Actually... About that... There's been a change of plans."

"Huh? What do you mean?"

"Well, I have decided to surprise Yu Rou in a different manner. There will be a public concert on the day of her birthday. I want you to bring Yu Rou to the concert without letting her realize the truth. I'm sorry if this will inconvenience you." Yuan explained.

"Of course not. I will make sure to send Yu Rou to the concert without fail. But does this mean you no longer want to visit our Eternal Lotuses' headquarters?" White Lotus asked.

"I don't want to trouble you or your faction since—"

"It's no trouble at all! And since I have already prepared for your visit at the faction, it would be a waste if you didn't show up."

"If you say it like that, I guess I can visit your faction and see for myself how my sister has been living lately." Yuan nodded.

The food arrived shortly after, and they stopped talking temporarily to eat.

"Wow, this food is delicious!" Yuan said in a pleasantly surprised voice as he constantly shoved food inside his mouth.

"I'm glad you enjoy it." White Lotus smiled.

An hour later.

'He really finished everything...White Lotus was impressed by Yuan's eating talent.

After the workers there cleaned up the table, they resumed their conversation.

"There's still another two days before Yu Rou's birthday. What do you plan on doing until then?" White Lotus asked.

"We'll probably just look around the city. Meixiu still needs to buy Yu Rou a birthday present, too."

"I see... Then do you mind if I tag along with you guys? I can be your guide." White Lotus asked.

"Are you sure? What about your faction? Won't they become suspicious if you're gone for too long?"

"It's fine. I rarely get involved with the members, anyway. And it's only for two days. I have been gone for longer before. Oh, if you're worried that I might attract too much attention, I can go in a disguise."

"You're even going as far as disguising yourself? I kind of feel bad for making you do so much work just to guide us around."

"It's fine. It's also my desire to spend more time with you." White Lotus said with a slightly blushing face.

"T-There's still a lot I want to talk to you about, too! Especially after our conversation in Cultivation Online."

"If you really want to come with us, I won't stop you." Yuan said a moment later.

"Thank you!" White Lotus showed a beaming smile.

However, that smile would disappear a moment later when someone shouted, "W-Wait! You can't go out there!"

"Do you know who I am?! Get out of my way! I have business with White Lotus and the bastard she's meeting with! I know she's out there!"

"Hey!"

A tall figure suddenly stormed through the guards and onto the roof, where Yuan and the others were.

"Who's that?" Yuan asked.

"I'm really sorry. That's Zheng Weimin, and he's been infatuated with me for a while now, to the point where he's stalking me. Don't worry, I will deal with him immediately."

White Lotus left the table and approached the young man.

"Zheng Weimin! I don't remember inviting you! How dare you barge in here and disturb my important meeting with an esteemed guest! I will give

you three seconds to turn around and leave before I toss you out myself!"

Zheng Weimin pointed at her body with trembling hands and roared, "Look at you! Who are you trying to seduce with such a slutty dress?!"

He then turned to look at Yuan and continued, "Is it him?! Is that the bastard you're trying to seduce?! Not on my watch!"

"Wow... What a guy..." Chu Liuxiang mumbled, finding the situation to be incredibly amusing for some reason.

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AN: This is the bonus chapter for reaching 1k power stones for 'Magic System in a Parallel World'.

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Chapter 957 - Young Master Zheng

"That's it! I have had enough of your nonsense!" White Lotus started approaching Zheng Weimin aggressively.

"What do you think you're doing, White Lotus? Do you really dare to lay your hands on me?! In case you forgot, your Bai Family is only ranked 7th in the Legacy Ranking whilst my Zheng Family is ranked 5th, not even mentioning our allies! Touch even a hair on my body and I will start a war with your Bai Family!"

White Lotus gritted her teeth in frustration.

"I don't care even if you're ranked first in the Legacy Ranking! I will not forgive you for your actions today!"

"White Lotus." Yuan's calm voice suddenly resounded, causing her to halt and turn to look at him.

"That anger does not suit your face," he said with a smile.

"..." White Lotus' face immediately flushed with redness.

When Zheng Weimin saw White Lotus' face, his anger skyrocketed to a new level, and he immediately started power walking towards Yuan's table.

"Wait—" White Lotus tried to stop him, but Yuan gestured for her to stop.

Yuan stood up from his seat and faced Zheng Weimin directly.

"I don't know who you are, but you have guts. I will give you that."

Yuan smiled and said, "I don't know what business you have with White Lotus, but can you do it another time? We're having an important conversation right now."

"I don't give a rat's ass about your conversation. Nobody talks to my woman without my permission!"

"That's not very reasonable..." Yuan shook his head in a pitiful manner.

"Reasoning? Hah! Who cares about reasoning! Do you know who I am?! My surname is Zheng! My family is ranked 5 in the Legacy Ranking!"

'Legacy... I wonder if they have anything to do with the Seven Legacy Families in the Nine Heavens.' Yuan wondered inwardly.

"Sorry, but I'm not really knowledgeable about the Legacy Ranking, so your words mean nothing to me."

"Don't worry, the only words you need to understand are— If you dare come near my woman again, I will make you regret being born!"

Zheng Weimin suddenly glanced at Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang and grinned, "Are they your women? They're not bad. How about I take them from you so you know how it feels?"

"Let's not involve my friends in your nonsense."

"And who are you to stop me?!" Zheng Weimin suddenly moved and reached for Meixiu with his claw-like hands.

However, before he could even get close to Meixiu, Yuan extended his hands and grabbed Zheng Weimin by the neck faster than one can blink their eyes.

"Get your hands off Young Master Zheng!"

His guards that had been in the background started flooding the roof, even pointing their pistols at Yuan.

However, Yuan acted like he couldn't even see them and proceeded to walk towards the edge of the building with Zheng Weimin still in his hold.

The guards didn't dare to actually shoot their guns, as they were afraid of hitting Zheng Weimin by accident.

Once Yuan was at the edge of the building, everybody there expected him to stop, but to their absolute shock, Yuan continued walking off the edge of the building.

"ARE YOU INSANE?!"

"YOUNG MASTER!"

The guards and White Lotus freaked out when they saw this.

However, contrary to their expectations, Yuan didn't fall off the building and actually continued walking in the air, almost as though there was an invisible platform underneath him.

"W-What the hell is going on?" White Lotus mumbled in a dazed voice, wondering if her eyes were playing tricks on her.

Once he was a few meters away from the roof, Yuan stopped walking and spoke in a calm voice, "I don't care if you badmouth me, but don't you dare try to touch my precious friends with your dirty hands."

Zheng Weimin wanted to scream, but Yuan had cut off his voice by choking him. He also wanted to break free from Yuan's grasp, but seeing that the floor was hundreds of meters at the bottom, he didn't dare to even move, as he would fall to his death from this height even with his first level Spirit Warrior cultivation base.

"I have killed thousands of people inside Cultivation Online, but I have never killed someone in this world. Do you wish to be the first?" Yuan asked him in a cold voice.

"N... No...!" Zheng Weimin muttered in a mosquito-like voice.

"Too late." Yuan suddenly released his hold on Zheng Weimin, letting him fall down.

"AAAAHHHHHHHHHH! I DON'T WANT TO DIE!!!" Zheng Weimin cried in a hysterical voice as his bladder gave up on him during the free fall.

"Hmph."

When Zheng Weimin was a moment away from turning into meat paste on the street, Yuan caught him and flew back to the roof of the hotel.

Once they were on the roof again, Yuan tossed Zheng Weimin, who had lost consciousness and sullied his pants, in front of his guards.

"Get that fool out of here. He's dirtying this place with his filth. Oh, and tell him to stop bothering White Lotus when he wakes up." Yuan said to the guards, who were in a daze trying to comprehend what they'd just witnessed.

"Guards! Get them out of here!" White Lotus shouted after snapping out of her daze.

Very quickly, the guards working for her escorted Zheng Weimin and his men out of the hotel.

"I'm really sorry about what just happened! I will make this up to you! I swear!" White Lotus apologized to them with her head lowered.

Yuan casually waved his hand, "Don't worry about it. You can put all of the blame on that guy."

Once White Lotus calmed down, she asked him, "By the way... What on earth was that just now? You were..."

"Flying?" Yuan interrupted.

She nodded eagerly.

"You'll be able to fly as well once you reach Spirit Grandmaster," he said.

Although he wasn't able to immediately start flying after reaching Spirit Grandmaster and had to rely on his sword to fly, he practiced his Qi Manifestation almost everyday and managed to finally fly just a week ago.

"No way..." White Lotus muttered in a baffled voice, still not daring to believe it.

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Chapter 958 - Legacy Ranking

"Do you want to try it?" Yuan suddenly asked.

"Try? Try what?"

"Flying."

White Lotus swallowed nervously after hearing his words, and the scene of Yuan soaring through the clouds while carrying her like a princess appeared in her mind.

"Are you sure? I might be a little heavy..." White Lotus said with a stiff smile.

Although she really wanted to experience flying in the sky, she didn't have the courage to accept his offer, especially when she's wearing such a revealing dress.

"Don't worry, it'll be fine." Yuan smiled.

After a moment of silence, White Lotus nodded in a bashful manner, "Then I'll accept your offer."

Hearing her words, Yuan summoned the Empyrean Overlord and pointed at it, "Go ahead. Stand on it."

"Huh?" White Lotus looked at him with a dumbfounded face.

"I'll carry you around with my flying sword. It'll feel much better than having me carry you in my arms."

"Oh... All right..." White Lotus nodded, feeling a little disappointed that Yuan will not be carrying her.

Once she was standing on the Empyrean Overlord, White Lotus asked, "By the way, where did this sword come from?"

Yuan chuckled, "I will explain it another day since it's a bit complicated."

White Lotus nodded and didn't question any further.

"Is this your first time riding a flying sword? Have you done it before in Cultivation Online?"

"This is my first time," she said.

"Then I will hold your hand until you're comfortable with letting go." Yuan offered his hand to White Lotus, who immediately accepted it without hesitation.

"I will be back in a bit." Yuan said to Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang.

"Have fun!" Chu Liuxiang waved at them.

Yuan flew into the air with White Lotus shortly after.

White Lotus immediately tightened her grasp on Yuan's hands after feeling the sword move.

They started out slow, gradually increasing their flying speed until they maxed out at 20 miles per hour.

"What do you think about flying?" Yuan asked White Lotus.

"It's a little scary being this high up, but I really enjoy it."

"How long can you maintain being in the air?" She then asked.

"I can fly for an hour straight if I were by myself, but since I am also carrying you, I will only be able to fly for about half an hour." Want to see

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"I see..."

"Are you ready to let go of my hand?" Yuan asked her a few moments later.

"Yes." White Lotus nodded, and she slowly relaxed her hands.

"How am I doing?" She asked him afterward.

"You're doing great. Do you want me to speed up more?"

"Sure."

Yuan increased their speed by another 5 miles per hour after White Lotus' approval.

"How fast does this thing go?" White Lotus asked out of curiosity.

"Do you want to see for yourself?" Yuan smiled at her.

White Lotus swallowed nervously, but she nodded her head regardless.

"Brace yourself. I will go at maximum speed in three... two... one!"

Whoosh!

The flying sword suddenly quadrupled in speed, going at nearly 100 miles per hour.

"Ahhhh!" White Lotus shouted, as she was not expecting such an explosive boost.

After remaining on the sword for a few seconds, White Lotus could no longer keep up with the speed and actually fell off the flying sword, and she started plunging towards the ground.

"Yuan!" She cried out loud.

Yuan quickly went to catch her.

"Are you okay?" He asked her.

"Yes... But that was horrifying... I now understand how Zheng Weimin felt when you dropped him..." White Lotus sighed in relief.

Once she calmed down, she realized that Yuan was carrying her like a princess, and one of his hands was even touching her breasts.

"..." White Lotus blushed when she felt Yuan's fingers firmly pressing against the side of her breasts, but she kept her mouth closed and didn't say anything, silently enjoying the situation.

"By the way..." Yuan suddenly spoke, "The Zheng Family might try to cause trouble for your family after what happened today. If that happens, you can let me know and I will do my best to assist your family. I hate people who think they can do anything because of their status— people like Zheng Weimin."

"Thank you, Yuan. I will remember your words, but my Bai Family is not weak. If the Zheng Family wishes to bully us, we will not stay silent and fight back."

After pondering for a bit, Yuan said, "I was not lying when I said that I don't know much about the Legacy Ranking. While I prefer staying out of their business, I have a feeling that I will encounter more people like Zheng Weimin in the future, so I might as well gather information now."

"You want to know more about the Legacy Ranking, right? I will tell you everything you need to know whenever you want." White Lotus said.

"Thank you."

After flying around for a few more minutes, Yuan returned to the hotel with White Lotus still in his arms.

"Thank you for the wonderful experience, Yuan. I will never forget it for the rest of my life." White Lotus said to him with a beautiful smile on her face.

"I had fun, too."

Sometime later, they returned to the table.

After ordering some drinks, White Lotus began explaining to them the Legacy Ranking and how it works.

"There are 100 slots in the Legacy Ranking from Rank 1 to Rank 100. In order to join the Legacy Ranking, you must have one thing— results."

"As you probably know, video games have been immensely popular even before Cultivation Online's existence, so much so that it has ingrained itself into the majority of peoples' lives, where over half of the world's population play games to make a living."

"With how important video games have become in our world, it was only natural for people to want to monetize it. One thing led to another, and the Legacy Ranking was born, where families from all over the world fight for the top rankings in whichever video game is chosen to be the focus for that decade."

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Chapter 959 - I Want Him Dead!

Chapter 959 - I Want Him Dead!

"Besides wealth and fame, what do you get for being part of the Legacy Ranking?" Yuan asked.

"Influence and social status." White Lotus calmly replied.

"I get the meaning behind the Legacy Ranking, but how does it actually work?" Chu Liuxiang suddenly asked.

"If we're going by rankings, doesn't it mean Yuan, who is the current number one player in Cultivation Online, number one in the Legacy Ranking?"

"Yes and no. In order to enter the Legacy Ranking, you must participate in a tournament that is held every year. You need at least 10 people in your 'family' to participate. While Yuan is, without doubt, the number one player in Cultivation Online, it doesn't mean he will automatically take first place in the Legacy Ranking."

"Yuan, why don't you join this year's tournament and show the Legacy Families who's boss?" Chu Liuxiang chuckled at this idea.

White Lotus immediately started sweating after hearing Chu Liuxiang's words.

"A-Actually, since Yuan doesn't belong to any family, I think it would be for the best if he joined another family. Of course, I am not just saying this so I can recruit you into our family— even though I would love to."

"The other Legacy Families won't like it if a newly created family suddenly becomes Rank 1, and they will probably do everything in their power to prevent it from happening."

"So what you're saying is... They will try to mess with Yuan if he tries to join with his own family." Meixiu said.

"Unfortunately, that is exactly what will happen." White Lotus sighed.

"However, if you really want to start your own family, you can try forming alliances with other Legacy Families."

"What about factions? Can I join with my faction?" Yuan suddenly asked.

"Actually, yes, you can. It was implemented just recently, but factions are now able to participate in the Legacy Ranking."

"Are you really planning on joining the Legacy Ranking with your faction?" White Lotus looked at Yuan with a nervous gaze.

"Honestly, I couldn't care less about the Legacy Ranking. Whether it be wealth or influence, it doesn't mean anything to me. I created the faction so that I can always be with the people that are close to me, that's all."

"I see..." White Lotus was relieved to hear Yuan's words.

If he won't be participating in the Legacy Ranking, it won't be as chaotic and stressful.

However, nothing is set in stone and it is still too early to tell if Yuan will affect this year's Legacy Ranking.

Sometime later, White Lotus brought Yuan and the others to their rooms.

"You can use these three rooms for as long as you please. They are the best we have in the hotel."

"Thank you." They said.

After picking their own rooms, they moved their luggage inside.

"Do you plan on walking around the city anytime soon?" White Lotus asked them shortly after.

"We plan on doing it now." Yuan nodded.

"Can you give me a few minutes to prepare my disguise?" White Lotus then asked.

"Sure."

"Thank you very much." White Lotus went into the room right beside their room and proceeded to disguise herself.

A few minutes later, she returned to their side with a completely different appearance.

Her hair turned blonde, and even her eyes changed to a beautiful green color. As for her dress, she changed it into something more casual, and she even went out of her way to wear sunglasses like Yuan.

"How do I look?" She asked them.

"I wouldn't recognize you if I didn't know your identity beforehand." Yuan smiled.

"That's great."

They left the hotel shortly after and started walking around the city.

Of course, even with White Lotus disguised, their group still attracted plenty of attention because of Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang.

Meanwhile, at the Zheng Family's headquarters, Zheng Weimin was lying in his bed when he suddenly woke up screaming.

"AAAAAH! HELP ME! I'M FALLING!"

"Young Master! Calm down! You're not falling!" His servants quickly attended him.

"W-What?" Zheng Weimin looked at his surroundings with a puzzled face, his back soaked in cold sweat.

"Where am I? What happened?"

"You're in your own room right now, Young Master. You lost consciousness after what happened, so we carried you back here."

The servants did not dare to mention that he'd sullied his pants, so they left that detail out.

"THAT BASTARD! HOW DARE HE EMBARRASS ME IN FRONT OF WHITE LOTUS! I WANT HIM DEAD!" Zheng Weimin roared.

The servants started sweating, and they quickly reminded him of what happened, "Young Master, are you sure that's a good idea? That man could fly!"

"Do you really think humans can fly?! This is not Cultivation Online! He was obviously using some kind of trick to make it seem like he was flying!" Zheng Weimin shouted, clearly in denial.

"I believe we should investigate his identity before we act."

"Then hurry up and investigate him! I want to know everything about him! His family, his friends— everything!"

"Just you wait... I will show you what happens when you offend me! I am going to crush you and your insignificant life!"

"I also want the Bai Family to be held responsible for what happened today! Call my father and tell him that White Lotus from the Bai Family has assaulted me today!"

The servants quickly went to work after hearing Zheng Weimin's words. Despite knowing that Zheng Weimin was being unreasonable, they could

not defy his orders, and they were already used to it.

Sometime later, after hearing about what had happened to his precious son and how he'd almost died today, the head of the Zheng Family immediately contacted the Bai Family, demanding an explanation.

Of course, the Bai Family had expected their contact and even prepared for it.

While the Zheng Family was oblivious of Yuan's identity, the Bai Family knew very well that he was the one behind the incident today, so they took advantage of their knowledge to mess with the Zheng Family.

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Chapter 960 - Meeting Between Two Legacy Families

Chapter 960 - Meeting Between Two Legacy Families

Inside a private room, the Patriarch of the Bai Family stood before a projector that was projecting a video call.

On the other side of the call was the Patriarch of the Zheng Family.

The two of them had decided to video call each other to talk about the recent incident between White Lotus and Zheng Weimin.

"You claim that your son, Zheng Weimin, had gone to visit my daughter, Bai Lianhua, and returned beaten and humiliated without any good reason, but I heard a different story from my daughter."

"She claims that your son, Zheng Weimin, had rudely forced himself into a private meeting between my daughter and her clients. Not only that, he even insulted my daughter and her clients."

"That's a load of bullshit, Bai Mengyao! My son went to visit your daughter because he had something important to tell her, but he was assaulted and humiliated before he could even speak with her! He was even beaten unconscious!"

"Zheng Ye, there's no need to sugar your words. We both know that your son is obsessed with my daughter. We have told your Zheng Family many times that Bai Lianhua does not wish to be with Zheng Weimin, yet he keeps on causing trouble for her, which causes trouble for my family." Bai Mengyao shook his head.

"Don't try to change the subject, Bai Mengyao! We're talking about how your daughter attacked my son! No matter their relationship, that won't change the fact that my son had been beaten by her!" Zheng Ye slammed his desk in anger.

"Now that's where you're wrong." Bai Mengyao shook his head again.

"How am I wrong?!"

"My daughter did not lay a hand on your son. It was her client who had an altercation with Zheng Weimin, so you're speaking with the wrong person right now. If you really want to seek justice for your son, you should probably go speak with the young man who felt the need to beat your son. Though, I'm sure he has a good reason, especially considering Zheng Weimin's bad reputation."

Zheng Weimin gritted his teeth in frustration. He knew that White Lotus hadn't touched his son. However, he could not let go the chance to blame the Bai Family that has been refusing to give their Zheng Family face for years now by rejecting Zheng Weimin's proposal to White Lotus.

"I don't care if your daughter touched him or not! As the host, she should've kept her client in check! Like how we're responsible for our dogs' actions, White Lotus is responsible for her clients' actions!"

Bai Mengyao suddenly laughed out loud.

"What's so funny?!" Zheng Ye frowned.

"My daughter should keep that person in check? You have no idea who her client even is! Let me warn you, Zheng Ye, that young man your son had offended is not someone the Zheng Family can afford to offend, much less my Bai Family!"

'What? Someone even my family cannot offend?' The frown on Zheng Ye's face sank even further down.

"There is nobody that my Zheng Family cannot handle! We may be ranked fifth in the Legacy Ranking, but our influence surpasses even the 3rd rank!"

"Suit yourself. And don't even bother trying to ask me for information on that person. I don't feel like offending him, so if you'll excuse me, I have other business that I need to attend."

"Don't you dare run away from—"

Bai Mengyao ignored him and closed the video call.

"What a pain in the ass. However, this is a good opportunity to see just how powerful this Player Yuan is... He may be powerful in Cultivation Online, but the real world is a whole different game. Will he be able to deal with the Zheng Family like how he'd dealt with the Cultivators' Association?"

Bai Mengyao kind of hoped that Yuan would get pushed into a corner by the Zheng Family so that his Bai Family could come to his rescue and make him owe their family.

Sometime later, the Bai Family contacted White Lotus to notify her of the situation.

"I understand. I will warn him."

After closing the line, White Lotus said to Yuan, "It appears that the Zheng Family had tried to pressure my family."

"Is your family okay?" He asked.

"For now, yes, but there's a good chance that the Zheng Family will continue to harass my family until we compromise. My family also told me to warn you that the Zheng Family will be coming after you as well."

"Why am I not surprised?" Yuan shook his head.

"Knowing the Zheng Family, they will go after your friends and family if they learn of your true identity as Yu Tian. However, only very few higher ups in my family, myself, and Jasmine, know that." White Lotus said.

"Honestly, I don't care even if they find out about my identity. I will even be grateful to them if they caused trouble to the Yu Family." Yuan chuckled.

"What about Yu Rou...?" White Lotus looked at him with raised eyebrows.

"Your faction will protect her, right?"

"Of course! I swear on my name and reputation as the leader of the faction that no harm will come to your sister, Yu Rou!" She immediately responded.

Yuan smiled and said, "Thank you, but if they really target Yu Rou, your faction won't have the chance to protect her, as I will destroy the entire Zheng Family before they can even act."

White Lotus swallowed nervously after seeing how Yuan spoke about crushing the Zheng Family so causally. It was almost like the Zheng Family couldn't even be considered ants in his eyes.

'Just how powerful are you, Yuan?' White Lotus sighed inwardly.

Their group continued to wander the city without a care in the world, almost like their trouble with the Zheng Family was nonexistent.

At the end of the day, they returned back to the hotel.

"I couldn't find a birthday present for Yu Rou today even though we looked at many stores..." Meixiu sighed.

"Don't worry, you still have tomorrow." Chu Liuxiang said to her.

"I guess..."

Shortly after returning to the hotel, White Lotus invited them for dinner, which they accepted.

Chapter 961 - Nightmare in Broad Daylight

Chapter 961 - Nightmare in Broad Daylight

"Wow, it's like a whole different world up here at night." Chu Liuxiang stared at the city from the roof of the hotel as they waited for the food to arrive.

"The Dragon Spiral Mountain may have much better spiritual energy, but it cannot compare to this place when it comes to scenery."

"You're free to move to this hotel if you want." White Lotus said in a joking voice.

Dinner lasted for about an hour and half.

Afterward, everyone retired in their own room.

"I will see you all tomorrow." White Lotus said to them.

"Yes, good night."

After a quick shower, Yuan entered the massive bed that could easily fit six people and laid there.

'It's been a while since I've slept alone in a bed.' Yuan realized this fact very quickly.

Inside Chu Liuxiang's room, she stared at the cold, empty bed and sighed, "I've gotten too comfortable sleeping with Yuan that I'd forgotten how it feels sleeping alone."

Meanwhile, White Lotus received a phone call from her family.

"What's the situation now?" White Lotus' father, Bai Mengyao asked.

"We just finished dinner and the guests are resting in their room," she said.

"How is Yuan?"

"He's doing great. It's almost like the incident this morning with Zheng Weimin never happened for him."

"I see... What about you? How do you feel after spending an entire day with him? Let me hear your impressions."

"Yuan is a very charming young man. I can tell that he's a genuinely kind person. He's also very humble considering his reputation. I would've never guessed that he was Player Yuan if I didn't already know it beforehand."

"However, I have to admit, he's also a little scary, especially when angered. He's someone that I wouldn't want to offend."

Bai Mengyao suddenly started laughing behind the phone.

"What a surprise! To think that my daughter, who has always disliked men, would have such a high impression on this young man!"

White Lotus blushed after hearing her father's words.

A few moments later, Bai Mengyao stopped laughing and spoke in a serious voice, "I'm glad that you like him. However, the real question is, when will you make your move on him?"

White Lotus turned silent for a moment before speaking, "I think it's a little too early..."

"The slower you move, the more time you give others!"

"I know, but I really don't think I should move now. The two women Yuan brought with him... They're both incredibly beautiful and charming young

ladies, and despite acting like they're only friends with each other, I have no doubt that they're his lovers."

"It wouldn't be a wise choice for me to invade their territory at this moment. In fact, I will most likely need their approval before I can join them."

"If I force myself into their relationship, it would only have a negative effect."

Bai Mengyao took several moments to ponder about White Lotus' words.

"Fine, you don't have to seduce him now. However, don't wait too long."

"Yes, father."

White Lotus released a deep sigh after hanging up the phone, feeling immense pressure on her shoulders.

"Although I don't mind having Yuan as my partner... Can I even seduce someone like him? Do I have what it takes to accept the fact that there will be other women in his life? The thought of sharing my husband with other women has never even crossed my mind... This is ridiculous."

Panda Novel White Lotus proceeded to ponder her situation for the rest of the night.

The following morning, after eating breakfast, Yuan and the others left the hotel for another day of touring the city.

'I really hope that I find a present for Yu Rou today...' Meixiu sighed inwardly as they walked from shop to shop.

After touring the city for the whole morning, White Lotus suggested to them, "Let's get some lunch. I know of the perfect restaurant, and it's only a few blocks away from this place."

"That's a good idea." Yuan nodded.

"Let's go." The other two also agreed.

"Great! Follow me."

On their way to the restaurant, White Lotus would talk about her previous experience there.

Halfway there, right as they reached the end of the street and was stopped by the red traffic light, Yuan suddenly started having a bad feeling, almost as though his intuition was warning him.

Trusting his guts, Yuan decided to expand his divine sense until it covered the entire street.

That's when he noticed a black van driving towards their street.

Yuan didn't think too much of this black van at first, but the feeling in his guts got more uncomfortable as the black van got closer to their location.

A few moments later, right as the traffic lights turned green, the black van stopped right in the middle of the crosswalk with its side facing Yuan and the others.

"Watch out!" Yuan suddenly shouted.

Right as Yuan's voice resounded, loud banging sounds filled the streets, and hundreds of small holes would appear on the side of the van that was facing his direction within seconds.

There were multiple people in the black van, and they were all shooting at Yuan's group from inside the van with deadly assault rifles.

"Aaaaah!"

Chaos immediately ensued, and the people in the street started scrambling to safety.

White Lotus and the others subconsciously tried to dodge the incoming bullets, but they quickly realized that something was preventing them from moving.

"Don't move!" Yuan shouted as he held his hands in front of him, using his Qi Manifestation to create a wall of spiritual energy in front of them, protecting them from the bullets. Of course, he was also responsible for restricting their movements.

The bullets that touched Yuan's invisible wall would get caught in his spiritual energy, making it seem like time had stopped for the bullets.

However, despite this, bullets continued to fly without mercy, turning the street into a warzone.

Yuan gritted his teeth in frustration. As much as he wanted to use his flying dagger to retaliate, he did not dare to split his focus, putting all of his attention on defense and the wall before them, which was the only thing preventing the bullets from riddling their bodies with holes.

Chapter 962 - Assassination Attempt

Chapter 962 - Assassination Attempt

The sound of powerful guns blazing through bullets continued nonstop for another minute until the people in the black van eventually ran out of bullets.

"We're out! Let's get the fuck out of here!"

The people in the black van didn't even bother to check whether their targets had survived before stepping on the gas and speeding away from the crime scene.

However, Yuan didn't dare to remove the wall until he was absolutely sure that the threat had completely vanished.

"Are you guys okay?!" Yuan turned around to ask the three terrified ladies standing behind him with shivering legs.

"I-I'm okay..." White Lotus muttered in a trembling voice.

"I am fine as well..." Chu Liuxiang said.

"Me too." Meixiu said.

"Meixiu! You're totally not fine! Look at your arm! It's bleeding!" Chu Liuxiang suddenly said in a panicked voice and pointed to her left arm, where blood could be seen flowing from a wound.

"Oh, you're right." Meixiu looked at her arm and said in a calm voice.

After inspecting the wound, she continued, "I'm fine, it's just a graze."

"How can you be so calm about this...? You just got shot!" Chu Liuxiang was dumbfounded by her reaction.

"Anyways, what in god's name was that just now?!"

"It was most likely the Zheng Family trying to exact revenge. I don't have any proof, but they're the only ones who have a motive." White Lotus sighed.

"Even if they want revenge, to think they'd go this far... This is unforgivable..." She looked at the destruction caused by the shooting just now.

Fortunately, there were no deaths. However, some people there were injured in the process of trying to run away, and the buildings behind their group were riddled with bullets.

Everyone there turned to look at Yuan, who was awfully silent for some reason, but that only made the ladies even more nervous.

Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang suddenly recalled what happened with the Gu Family when they threatened to hurt them. However, this incident was many times worse than the Gu Family, and Meixiu even got physically hurt in the process, so they cannot even begin to imagine what was going through Yuan's head.

"Are you okay, Yuan?" White Lotus decided to ask him.

To their surprise, he nodded and spoke in an abnormally calm voice, "Yes, I am just relieved that you're safe. Let's return to the hotel and get your wound treated, Meixiu."

"Okay..."

As they made their way back to the hotel, police sirens could be heard blaring in almost every street.

"Yes, that really just happened." White Lotus spoke to her father through the phone as they walked, notifying him of the horror they'd just experienced.

"That fucking Zheng Family! How dare they try to assassinate you guys! They have crossed the line a thousand times! Don't worry, I will make sure they are held accountable for their actions! I'm just really glad that none of you are hurt!"

"By the way, has Yuan said anything about the situation?" Bai Mengyao suddenly asked.

"N-No... He's awfully quiet, nor has he spoken a word since we left..." White Lotus answered in a whispering voice.

"That doesn't sound very good. Do whatever you can to comfort him."

"I understand."

After hanging up the phone, Bai Mengyao called the Zheng Family and demanded for Zheng Ye to pick up the phone.

"I'm sorry, Mister Bai, but Mister Zheng is currently busy."

"I don't give a fuck if he's busy! I want him to answer the phone even if he's screwing his wife as we speak! If I don't hear from him within the next five minutes, I will literally shoot up your fucking headquarter!"

"P-Please calm down, Mister Bai—"

Di.

Panda Novel Bai Mengyao hung up and waited for his phone to ring.

As expected, Zheng Ye video called him three minutes later.

"For you to threaten my family with harm, you better have a good reason, Bai Mengyao, or you will be hearing from my lawyers."

"You dare to act like you don't know anything?! Your Zheng Family just tried to assassinate my daughter!"

"What?" Zheng Ye frowned upon hearing this, showing legit confusion.

"Hold your horses, Bai Mengyao. That is a serious accusation! I don't know what happened, but our Zheng Family was not involved!"

"You don't know what happened? Bullshit! Turn on the T.V and look at the news!"

Zheng Ye turned on his T.V the next moment. It didn't take long for him to learn of the shooting, as it was being covered by literally every news channel out there.

[About half an hour ago, a mass shooting had occurred at... Over 1,000 bullets had been fired... Miraculously, nobody was killed...]

"You're claiming that my Zheng Family had something to do with this shooting?! That's absurd! We would never do something like this!"

"As if I could believe your words! Only your Zheng Family has a motive!"

"This is defamation! Slander! Do you have any proof that it was my Zheng Family that is behind the shooting?!"

"The only proof I need is your Zheng Family's dogshit reputation! In the entire Legacy Ranking, your family is the worst!"

"Hah! You'll need more than that bullshit to do anything to us! Go ahead and sue us! I dare you!"

Bai Mengyao suddenly started laughing.

"What's so damn funny?! You think this is funny?!"

"You damn fool!" Bai Mengyao roared.

"I purposefully kept this a secret because I wanted your family to mess with him a little, but I truly did not expect for you to do something this daring. You guys truly went above and beyond! However, I am also at fault. Due to my selfish decision, my daughter was nearly assassinated!"

"What the hell are you talking about?" Zheng Ye frowned, as he had a bad feeling about Bai Mengyao's words.

"Listen carefully, Zheng Ye! The young man who trashed your useless son — the person your family just tried to assassinate today is none other than Player Yuan! The same Yuan your family is so desperately trying to recruit!" Bai Mengyao revealed the truth to him.

"What?!" Zheng Ye cried out loud, not daring to believe his ears.

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Chapter 963 - The Real Culprit

Chapter 963 - The Real Culprit

"T-That young man who beat my son was Player Yuan?! Impossible! I won't fall for this!" Zheng Ye was in denial.

However, inside his mind, he started recalling a certain rumor that White Lotus had managed to contact Player Yuan in Cultivation Online.

"I don't care if you believe it or not. However, it is a fact that your family had just tried to assassinate Player Yuan! If the other families learn of this, nobody will dare to stay by your side!" Bai Mengyao shouted.

"Stop! I swear on my ancestors' graves that our Zheng Family had nothing to do with the assassination! Do you really think that I would do something as blatant and reckless as shooting up a street in broad daylight?!"

Bai Mengyao frowned, and he started wondering if the Zheng Family had truly called in the assassination on Yuan.

"Anyways, do not bother me or my family again until you have concrete proof that it was my family who ordered the hit! And if you dare spread such rumors, I will sue you for slander!"

Zheng Ye closed the video call shortly after and started pacing back and forth his room with a panicked expression on his face.

He was telling the truth when he claimed that he had nothing to do with the assassination attempt, but he had a feeling that he knew the true culprit behind this madness.

He eventually picked up his phone and called his son, Zheng Weimin.

"Hello?" Zheng Weimin picked up the phone after a few rings.

"You crazy bastard! What have you done?! Tell me you are not behind the shooting this afternoon!" Zheng Ye's voice was so loud that it dazed Zheng Weimin.

However, to his surprise, Zheng Weimin spoke in a calm voice, "Huh? They already got to work? What a pleasant surprise! I really thought it would take at least a few days!"

"Y-You... Are you serious?" Zheng Ye could feel his legs giving out on him after hearing his son's words.

"Yes, I am. I was the one who ordered the hit on that bastard, so what? This will teach White Lotus what will happen if she dares to approach any man that is not me!" Zheng Weimin laughed out loud.

'This bastard's gone insane! Did he hit his head during his fight with Yuan?' Zheng Ye cried inwardly.

He always knew that his son was a crazy bastard, but even he couldn't have anticipated that his son would be crazy enough to hire assassins!

'I have underestimated him! This is bad! Really bad!'

"Don't worry, father." Zheng Ye suddenly said.

"I made sure there were no traces or evidence of my involvement, so they won't be able to hold us accountable."

Zheng Ye sighed out loud and said, "Have you seen the news?"

"No, I haven't. Why?" Zheng Ye asked in a puzzled voice.

"There were no deaths. In other words, your assassination attempt has failed."

"What?! How is that possible! I told them to use the strongest firearms they have available! Not even a Spirit Master cultivator could survive such

firepower!"

"Well, not only did they survive, but White Lotus was also there at the time of the attack, so you almost had your beloved assassinated alongside the man you're trying to kill."

"WHAT?! I gave those bastards specific instructions to not attack when White Lotus is near the target! Those useless bastards! I paid them a hefty fee, too!" Zheng Weimin cursed out loud.

Since White Lotus was in a disguise, the attackers did not recognize her, but Zheng Weimin wasn't aware of this fact.

Zheng Ye sighed, and he proceeded to ask, "You... Do you even know the identity of the man who you just tried to have assassinated today?"

"His identity doesn't matter. Since he dared to offend me, he's a dead man!"

"Player Yuan! That man was Player Yuan! Do you have any idea what this means?!" Zheng Ye suddenly yelled.

"W-What?" Zheng Weimin muttered in a dazed voice, seemingly having difficulties comprehending what he'd just heard.

"I really hope you didn't leave any evidence behind! If I learn that you've screwed up, I will, without hesitation, kick you out of the family and disown you!"

"B-But father! So what if he's Player Yuan?! He's just a nobody who got lucky in Cultivation Online!"

"Do you have any idea how many families within the Legacy Rankings are looking to curry favors with this nobody?! If they learn that you tried to assassinate Yuan, they will definitely side with him to destroy us!"

"I'm done talking with you! However, let me give you one more piece of advice as your father. Hide! Don't show your face until all of this calms down!"

Zheng Ye disconnected the line and tossed his phone at the wall, smashing it into pieces.

"FUCK! THAT FUCKING CRAZY BASTARD!"

Meanwhile, Zheng Weimin sat on his bed with a dazed look on his face.

"So he was Player Yuan all along... It all makes sense now... No wonder why she dared to fight back."

"However, none of that matters. They cannot touch me without proof."

"As for those assassins, even if they have failed their first attempt, they will continue to try until they fulfill our contract."

Zheng Weimin quickly stopped caring about the situation, as he was confident that he would not get in any trouble for his actions.

After all, there were rules and regulations in this world, and being in the Top 5 of the Legacy Rankings, these regulations were in his favor regardless if he was in the right or wrong.

"I don't care if you're Player Yuan! Come get me if you can! Hahaha!"
Zheng Weimin laughed like a madman inside his room.

Back at the hotel, White Lotus had the entire hotel secured by her guards so that not even a rat could enter or leave the premises— they were basically in lockdown.

Meanwhile, Meixiu had her wound inspected and treated by a professional.

Chapter 964 - Take Me to the Zheng Family

Chapter 964 - Take Me to the Zheng Family

"Luckily, the bullet only grazed your skin. I also checked your blood just in case they laced the bullets with poison. The results were negative. You'll heal in a few days." The doctor said to Meixiu after inspecting her grazed wound.

"Will this injury leave a scar?" Meixiu asked the doctor.

"Since you're a cultivator, it will only last for a bit. It will eventually disappear completely, but I will prescribe you with some healing cream just in case."

"I see... Thank you." Meixiu nodded.

Once the doctor left and they were alone, Chu Liuxiang spoke, "What should we do now? Yu Rou's birthday is tomorrow, and the concert will be held in public. If we don't deal with the situation before then, they could attack during the concert."

"Is there anything we can do to the Zheng Family?" She looked at White Lotus, who shook her head.

"Unfortunately, we don't have any concrete proof that the Zheng Family was the one behind the attack. My father spoke to the head of the Zheng Family, and according to what he told me, Zheng Ye doesn't appear to have anything to do with the attack."

"I also highly doubt they would leave behind any evidence that incriminates them."

"So there's nothing we can do about it?" Meixiu asked with a worried frown on her face.

"Not legally, no..." White Lotus sighed.

"We can try to look for the people in the black van, but we're still investigating that. The entire Bai Family is currently working with the police and investigators, but even with such a force, it will probably be a few days until we can learn anything."

"We don't have the luxury to wait that long." Yuan suddenly spoke.

"Do you have something in mind?" White Lotus asked him.

He nodded and said, "Meixiu, Lulu, I want the two of you to stay in this room together until I resolve our situation. It won't take too long, I promise."

"What are you going to do?" Meixiu asked him in a worried voice.

"I'm going to get the evidence we need to deal with whoever decided it was a good idea to put you all in such a dangerous situation," he calmly said.

Yuan approached Meixiu and caressed the bandage on her arm— where she'd been injured from the attack.

"The person who caused this will wish that they'd never been born..."

Even though his voices were as tranquil as still water in a lake, the ladies could feel the anger boiling within, and it was only a matter of time before it exploded, causing the water to splash everywhere.

Meixiu suddenly grabbed his hands and spoke, "Yuan, I know you're angry and that you're doing this for us, but please, don't do anything that will hurt you."

"I won't. I promise." Yuan showed her a gentle smile.

He then faced White Lotus and said, "Can you do me a favor?"

"O-Of course!" She immediately nodded.

"Let's go."

Yuan started making his way towards the exit.

"Don't do anything that you will regret later, Yuan! I know that you care about our safety, but don't forget that we also care about yours!" Chu Liuxiang shouted as he reached the door.

"I know." He responded as he left the room.

"I want guards inside and outside of this room at all times until we return. Make sure no harm comes to our guests." White Lotus said to Jasmine.

"What about you, Miss Bai?"

"I will be fine." White Lotus said as she glanced at Yuan.

"I understand. I will make sure the guests are protected even if it's the last thing I do." Jasmine nodded.

"Please take care of Miss Bai." She turned to face Yuan and bowed to him.

Sometime later, White Lotus followed Yuan to the roof of the hotel.

Yuan continued walking until he was standing at the edge of the building.

After standing there in silence for a couple of minutes, he suddenly asked, "Where is the Zheng Family?"

"The Zheng Family's headquarter is located in another city, but they have a branch family that is about an hour outside the city. Although you won't find the head of the family, Zheng Ye, there, you should be able to find Zheng Weimin."

"That is good enough."

He then asked, "Do you mind showing me the way? I promise you that no harm will come to you. I will also owe you."

"I don't mind. And you don't have to owe me anything. You saved my life today. I should be the one with the debt," she said.

"The only reason you guys were put in such a dangerous situation was because of me. I was their target. You guys just happened to be with me at the time of the attack."

"If you don't mind me asking, what are you going to do once we meet the Zheng Family? I doubt they will tell us the truth even if we threaten them."

After a moment of silence, Yuan spoke in a low but clear voice, "I don't know what I am going to do to them, but I know that it won't be very pretty."

White Lotus swallowed nervously.

"Do you plan on killing them all? Don't worry, the Bai Family will protect you no matter your decision."

Yuan turned to look at her with a profound smile on his face, but he did not respond to her question.

After a moment of silence, he spoke in a cold voice as he took off his sunglasses, revealing the red eyes that had been concealed by the shades, "That would be too lenient on the bastards that attacked us. I won't kill them, but I will make them wish that they were dead."

White Lotus' eyes widened with shock, and her body trembled in fear when she saw Yuan's crimson eyes that looked like it had been dyed in blood, not to mention intense killing intent that was contained within his gaze. However, mixed in with her fear was awe, as she was also oddly charmed by his presence.

Although she wasn't certain, she had a feeling that Yuan was looking at her through his eyes as of this moment.

Yuan lifted his arm and gestured for her, "Take me to the Zheng Family. It's our turn to surprise them."

"Yes." White Lotus responded in a low voice before grabbing his hand and flying into the air with him, her heart throbbing with excitement.

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Chapter 965 - Regaining His Vision

Chapter 965 - Regaining His Vision

As they made their way towards the Zheng Family, White Lotus couldn't help but stare at Yuan's handsome face and beautiful crimson eyes that resembled jewels.

"Yuan... Your eyes... What happened?" She couldn't resist her urge to ask him.

"I'm not really sure. After seeing Meixiu getting hurt from the assault, I felt something being 'released' within me, and before I knew it, I regained my vision."

"Huh? So you're no longer blind?" White Lotus muttered in a dumbfounded voice.

"For now. Who knows how long this would last. Maybe I'll return to being blind after a few hours."

Yuan turned to look at White Lotus' beautiful face and pale complexion.

"Even though I can see the world clearer and in more details with divine sense, there is just something unique about viewing the world with my eyes." He said with a smile.

"It's unfortunate that I had regained my vision during this time when I am unable to enjoy it." His smile quickly turned bitter.

White Lotus suddenly lowered her head and tightened her hold around his neck.

"My life flashed before my eyes earlier today. I have never had such a close near-death experience before— not even in Cultivation Online."

"Honestly, I've been in worse situations. However, I have never felt scared in those situations. It was different today. I was terrified, but not for myself. I was scared that I would lose one of you, and it was a close call. The bullet that grazed Meixiu could've killed any of us. Fortunately, that did not happen."

"You really care about Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang. I'm envious." White Lotus suddenly sighed.

"I care about you too, you know?" He said, taking her by surprise.

"Really? Even though we've just met each other?"

"Of course." He nodded.

"Thank you..." White Lotus mumbled as she lowered her head even more to prevent Yuan from seeing the expression on her face.

About half an hour later, White Lotus pointed at the large mansion located at the horizon and said, "Over there. That's our destination."

Yuan nodded and flew directly towards the mansion.

Once they landed near the mansion, Yuan stepped in front of White Lotus and said, "Stay behind me no matter what."

"Okay." She nodded.

Yuan summoned both Empyrean Overlord and Starry Abyss before approaching the mansion.

There were guards pacing around the mansion, and all of them were carrying fully loaded assault rifles.

"Are they usually this tight with security? Not even banks are this heavily guarded." Yuan asked her.

"No, this isn't normal." White Lotus shook her head.

"Then they must be really afraid of something." Yuan smiled.

"Follow me."

He walked out of the shadows with White Lotus behind him.

"HALT!"

The guards there immediately noticed him and pointed their guns at his direction without any hesitation.

"Identify yourself! What are you doing here?!"

"Let me handle this." White Lotus said.

"I'm Bai Lianhua! We're here to speak with Zheng Weimin!"

The guards recognized her name and face.

"Zheng Weimin is not here!" One of the guards said.

"You're lying." Yuan said, as he could sense Zheng Weimin's presence within the mansion.

"I will give you two choices. Get Zheng Weimin out here for me, or I will go inside to meet him myself."

"And I will give you one choice. Get lost before we fill your body with bullet holes!"

Yuan closed his eyes and took a deep breath.

The next moment, one of the guards suddenly screamed in pain, startling the others.

When they turned to look at him, they saw that his hands had suddenly been severed by something sharp.

"W-What happened?!"

However, before they could even make sense of what was happening, the invisible Starry Abyss honed in on its next target.

Whoosh!

"AAAAH! My hands!" Another guard had his hand severed.

Then another.

And another.

In less than a minute, Yuan had disarmed all of the guards there by severing their hands with the Starry Abyss.

White Lotus swallowed nervously after seeing the brutal scenery. The guards were all screaming in pain as blood gushed from their grievous wounds.

"Let's go." Yuan said with a nonchalant face as he started walking towards the entrance.

After smashing the doors with a single kick, Yuan entered the building with White Lotus.

However, the moment they took a step inside the building, the guards that had been waiting inside ambushed them, shooting their guns without hesitation.

Hundreds of bullets flew at Yuan every second, resembling the situation earlier this afternoon but with more noise and chaos, as there were more people shooting their guns at him.

However, there was one more difference.

Yuan was prepared for the attack this time.

While he used Qi Manifestation to create a wall around him and White Lotus, he also controlled the Starry Abyss to take down the shooters one at a time.

Since the shooters were spread out and most of them were focused on shooting Yuan, they failed to notice what was happening until it was too late and everyone there had their hands and arms severed.

'He's not killing them... Is he saving it for Zheng Weimin?' White Lotus noticed this and wondered to herself.

"Are you okay?" Yuan turned around and asked her in a calm voice.

"Y-Yes." She nodded in a dazed manner.

"Good, then let's continue."

Yuan proceeded to follow Zheng Weimin's presence in the mansion.

They would encounter guards at every turn, but Yuan easily took care of them.

Meanwhile, inside Zheng Weimin's room.

"What the fuck is going on out there?!" Zheng Weimin asked the guards in his room.

"We have intruders. Two of them. A man and a woman." The guard said.

"It's just two intruders! There are hundreds of you, all equipped with heavy firearms! Why the fuck am I still hearing gunshots after so long?! Are they all shooting at the sky or something?!" Zheng Weimin cried out loud.

"I-I don't know... Even I am puzzled..." The guard shook his head.

"Fuck! You're all so fucking useless!" Zheng Weimin gritted his teeth in frustration.

Chapter 966 - Punishing Zheng Weimin

Chapter 966 - Punishing Zheng Weimin

"Don't worry, Young Master. We will protect you with our lives." The guards in the room said to him.

"No fucking shit! If I die, my father will kill all of you!" Zheng Weimin shouted.

One of the guards' walkie talkie suddenly activated.

"H-Help! This guy is a monster! We cannot deal with him!" A terrified voice resounded from the walkie talkie.

"Give me that!" Zheng Weimin gestured for the walkie talkie.

Once it was in his hands, he shouted, "This is Zheng Weimin! What is happening out there?!"

However, the guard did not respond.

"Hello?! Hey! Answer me!"

After another moment of silence, the walkie talkie connected again.

"He can't hear you because he's unconscious. Probably due to blood loss, but I'm no expert. He might even be dead."

A familiar voice resounded from the walkie talkie. However, Zheng Weimin did not immediately recognize the voice.

"W-Who are you?!"

"You've already forgotten about me? It hasn't been that long since you tried to kill me." Yuan said in a calm voice.

"Y-You're that bastard from the roof! I have no idea what you're talking about! I never tried to kill you! What evidence do you have?!" Zheng Weimin finally realized who he was speaking to, and his body became soaked in cold sweat.

"Evidence? I don't have any."

"Then why the fuck are you creating a scene at my house?! I'll have you arrested for your actions!"

"I may not have any evidence now, but I will get some soon. I'll see you in a bit."

Yuan crushed the walkie talkie and continued making his way to Zheng Weimin's room.

"This fucking bastard!" Zheng Weimin tossed the walkie talkie at the wall in a fit of rage.

Shortly after their conversation ended, Zheng Weimin could hear the gunshots getting closer and closer to his room, pushing him towards the edge of having a mental breakdown.

Meanwhile, there were 12 guards inside his room, all of them pointing their guns at the door with their fingers on the trigger.

Ten minutes later, Yuan and White Lotus arrived at the hallway that contained Zheng Weimin's room.

"There are 13 people inside that room, one of them being Zheng Weimin. Stand back." Yuan said to her.

White Lotus nodded and took a few steps back.

Yuan held the Empyrean Overlord like a javelin and took a deep breath.

Whoosh!

He tossed the Empyrean Overlord, sending it flying through the hallway.

BANG!

The Empyrean Overlord smashed through the metal doors at the end of the hallway, revealing the terrified faces inside the room.

"OPEN FIRE!" The leader of the guards shouted.

Hundreds of bullets traveled the hallway until they reached Yuan, but they all stopped moving in front of him.

"W-What the fuck?!" The guards were shocked by what they were witnessing.

"Move out of the way!"

One of the guards there suddenly stepped forward and aimed a rocket launcher at Yuan.

"Yuan! Watch out!" White Lotus was terrified when she saw the RPG-7.

"Too late!"

The guard pressed the trigger, shooting the rocket at Yuan.

However, before it could even get anywhere near Yuan, the rocket exploded, blowing up half of the hallway and even some of the guards.

"What just happened?!" The guards that survived the explosion were dumbfounded.

Unbeknownst to them, Yuan had destroyed the rocket with the Starry Abyss.

"Ah! My arms!" One of the guards there suddenly screamed in pain as both his limbs suddenly separated from his body.

The other guards were terrified when they saw this, especially when none of them saw what had caused it.

Soon, every guard in the room had their hands and even entire arms severed by the invisible Starry Abyss.

Zheng Weimin stared at the nightmarish scene before him with a horrified look on his face.

"Y-You're not human! You're a fucking demon! Get away from me!" Zheng Weimin started crying when Yuan entered the room with White Lotus behind him.

White Lotus looked at Zheng Weimin's terrible appearance in silence.

"This is the result of offending Player Yuan. It's much worse than what I'd imagined..." She sighed inwardly.

"What's wrong? You look like shit." Yuan approached Zheng Weimin, who had backed all the way up to the corner of a wall.

"G-Get away from me! You will regret doing this to me!"

"What are you going to do? Report me to the police? Where's your evidence?"

"I have plenty of evidence and witnesses!" Zheng Weimin shouted.

"If I kill all of you and destroy this place, there won't be any more evidence." Yuan showed him a cold smile.

"Y-You wouldn't dare! I am innocent! I never tried to kill— Ahhhhh!"

Zheng Weimin suddenly screamed out loud, his voice filled with pain.

"Tell me again that you're innocent." Yuan spoke in a nonchalant voice as he removed his hand from Zheng Weimin's shoulder after crushing his bones.

Zheng Weimin gritted his teeth and spoke in a low voice, "I really don't know what you're talking— Ahhhh!"

Yuan crushed the rest of his arm with Qi Manifestation.

The pain of having every bone in his right arm being crushed was so intense that Zheng Weimin fell unconscious.

However, Yuan would wake him back up by breaking one of his legs by stomping on it.

"I can do this all day." Yuan said to him in a calm voice, almost as though he's done this thousands of times before.

"Give up, Zheng Weimin. It's over for you." White Lotus sighed.

"No! I am really innocent! Please! Believe me!" Zheng Weimin continued to claim his innocence despite the situation.

Yuan narrowed his eyes at Zheng Weimin.

'If physical pain isn't enough...'

After pondering for a moment, he turned to White Lotus and asked her, "Hey, this may be sudden, but have you ever kissed before?"

"Eh?!" Although she was taken by surprise by his question, White Lotus shook her head, "N-No..."

"I see..."

Yuan approached her the following moment.

"W-What are you doing?" Zheng Weimin stared at him with wide eyes.

Once he was standing in front of White Lotus, Yuan suddenly wrapped his arms around her waist and pulled her soft body into his embrace.

White Lotus was baffled by the sudden turn of events, but she didn't resist it.

"Do you mind if I become your first?" Yuan asked her with a profound expression on his face.

"YOU BASTARD!" Zheng Weimin roared out loud.

White Lotus realized what Yuan was trying to do now, and she couldn't help but feel a little disappointed.

However, this is exactly the type of situation she and her family wanted, so she didn't complain.

"It would be my pleasure to have you as my first." White Lotus nodded with a bashful smile before lifting her head and closing her eyes.

"N-No! NO! NO! NO! STOP IT! DON'T YOU DARE! I SWEAR I WILL KILL YOU IF YOU DO IT, YUAN!" Zheng Weimin shouted as blood in the form of tears began flowing from his eyes.

Yuan looked at Zheng Weimin with a mocking gaze before turning to focus on White Lotus, who had a flushed face at this moment.

He gently held her chin with his hand, and he slowly pressed his lips against hers, kissing her.

"YUUUUUUUUUUUUUUUUUAN!" Zheng Weimin could feel his heart being torn into countless pieces after witnessing the love of his life being stolen by his enemy before his very eyes.

Chapter 967 - It's Just a Kiss

Chapter 967 - It's Just a Kiss

"I WILL KILL YOU! I WILL KILL YOU! I WILL KILL YOU!!! YUUUUAAN!" Zheng Weimin shouted like a beast that had its children murdered before its eyes.

After kissing White Lotus, Yuan turned to look at Zheng Weimin's pathetic appearance and spoke, "Why are you so mad? It's just a kiss. And I don't recall White Lotus ever being your woman."

"SHUT UP! WHITE LOTUS IS MINE! MY WOMAN! HOW DARE YOU DEFILE HER WITH YOUR DIRTY MOUTH!"

Yuan narrowed his eyes on Zheng Weimin before speaking, "I'll do much more than just a kiss if you don't tell me the truth."

"W-What are you talking about?!" Zheng Weimin's eyes widened with shock.

Yuan turned to look at White Lotus and asked her, "Do you want to become my woman? I'll make you my woman right here and right now."

"YOU BASTARD! DON'T YOU DARE!" Zheng Weimin stared at them with bloodshot eyes.

If gazes could kill, Zheng Weimin would be able to kill even Immortals with his intense gaze.

Yuan suddenly hugged White Lotus and whispered in her ears, "Don't worry, I won't actually do anything to you."

White Lotus sighed inwardly, 'I wouldn't mind it even if you were for real...'

She then spoke in a genuine tone, "I am willing. If you want me to be your woman, both my body and heart are yours..."

To Yuan's surprise, White Lotus suddenly dragged him to the bed in the room and started loosening his clothes.

She then looked at Zheng Weimin and continued, "You have made my life miserable for many years with your harassment. Today, I will prove to you and the world that I am not your woman!"

She returned to looking at Yuan and gave him a seductive wink.

Before Yuan could react, White Lotus pulled his body on top of hers and started kissing him again, this time more passionately.

While they kissed, White Lotus began loosening her clothes as well.

"STOP! I ADMIT IT! I WAS THE ONE WHO ORDERED THE HIT ON YOU! I WAS WRONG!" Zheng Weimin could no longer endure the mental torture and admitted to his crimes.

However, White Lotus didn't seem to have any intention of stopping, mostly because she was too focused to hear Zheng Weimin's voice.

"WHY AREN'T YOU STOPPING?! I HAVE ALREADY CONFESSED!"

"..."

"He's already confessed. Let's stop here..." Yuan said to White Lotus before slipping away from her hold and getting off the bed.

White Lotus was reluctant, but she had no choice but to end the fun there.

After fixing their clothes, White Lotus asked, "What are you going to do to him now? Turn him to the authorities?"

Yuan narrowed his eyes on Zheng Weimin, who was lying on the floor with a half-dead look on his face.

"As long as he's alive, he will try to take revenge again. It may not happen tomorrow or even ten years from now, but I am not going to take any chances." Yuan spoke in a cold voice.

"Kill me if you want... I will haunt you for the rest of your life..." Zheng Weimin mumbled in a low voice.

"How did you contact the assassins?" He then asked.

"If you're trying to call off the hit on you, then you can give up. They won't stop until their target is dead, even if it takes a hundred years." Zheng Weimin chuckled.

Yuan went to take Zheng Weimin's cell phone and laptop a moment later.

"Let's go." He then said.

"Huh? Where are we going? Aren't you going to kill him?" White Lotus was baffled when Yuan started walking out of the room.

However, Yuan didn't respond to her until they were both outside the mansion.

"Are you really going to forgive him?"

"No, I am not." He said in a calm voice as he faced the mansion and summoned the Empyrean Overlord.

"Take twenty steps back," he then said.

White Lotus didn't question him and distanced herself from him.

Once she was far enough, Yuan took a deep breath and gathered his spiritual energy.

[Heaven Splitting Sword Strike!]

Yuan released the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike that contained about 90 percent of his strength.

A massive beam of light consumed the mansion and everyone within.

BOOM!

The mansion disappeared instantly, alongside over three miles of the wilderness behind the mansion.

"N-No way..." White Lotus fell to her knees upon witnessing the destruction caused by the Heavenly Splitting Sword Strike.

'With such power, he could easily wipe an entire city off the map!' She cried inwardly.

"This will not only erase the evidence of our involvement, but it will also serve as a warning to the Zheng Family." Yuan said in a calm voice.

White Lotus swallowed nervously.

After erasing the mansion, Yuan turned to face White Lotus and offered his hand to help her stand back up.

"T-Thank you..."

"I'm really sorry." He suddenly sighed.

"Huh? Why are you apologizing?"

"I took advantage of you today just to get back at Zheng Weimin, and I even took away your first kiss. I'm truly sorry." Yuan lowered his head and apologized again.

"I-It's fine!" White Lotus started waving her hand in a flustered manner.

"As you'd said, it's just a kiss. I am not so immature and innocent to care about something like that. And to tell you the truth, I wasn't lying when I said that I wanted you to be my first."

"However, if you wish to take responsibility and make me your woman, I won't object to it." White Lotus spoke in a teasing voice, yet her face was flushed with redness.

"L-Let's continue this conversation another time... I'm sure this place will be flooded with police soon, and we still have to deal with the assassins Zheng Weimin hired."

"All right. Then let us return to the hotel and see if Zheng Weimin had left any clues behind." White Lotus nodded.

Yuan carried White Lotus into the air and disappeared from the scene shortly after, returning to the hotel.

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Chapter 968 - Unknown Weapon of Mass Destruction

Chapter 968 - Unknown Weapon of Mass Destruction

After Yuan and White Lotus left the scene, helicopters and police cars flooded the place that used to be Zheng Family's branch family.

They were all stunned by the destruction there, and nobody there could imagine the kind of weapon that caused this mess.

"What in god's name happened here? Even a railgun would not be able to cause such destruction."

"Is this a new type of weapon? What could have transpired here that requires such immense power?"

"Hey, isn't this the location of the Zheng Family's mansion? I believe their oldest son, Zheng Weimin, lives here."

"Huh? Are you sure this is the right place?"

"Yes, I am certain that the Zheng Family had a mansion here."

"No way... Does that mean..."

"S-Somebody get in touch with the Zheng Family! This is an emergency!"

The investigators were shocked to learn that a mansion used to exist in this place.

Sometime later, Zheng Ye learned of the situation.

"What the fuck do you mean my family's mansion have disappeared?! Where is my son, Zheng Weimin?! Is he okay?!"

"I'm sorry, but we do not have any information on your son, but we are looking for him as we speak. Turn on the television, you should see for yourself the situation here..." The head investigator said to him.

Zheng Ye quickly turned on the television with a heavy heart.

"You have got to be fucking kidding me..." Zheng Ye nearly fell out of his seat after seeing the situation.

[About twenty minutes ago, an unknown weapon of mass destruction had detonated in this place, erasing over 1,000 acres of land! The authorities are still trying to figure out what happened here! If you have any information, please call them at...!]

[To think two horrifying incidents would occur in this city in such a short time... Just what on earth is happening? Could this be the work of terrorists?]

"As you can see, Mister Zheng... If your son had been inside or anywhere near the mansion at the time of the incident, it is very unlikely that he would've survived."

"No! NO! I told my son to leave that place when I spoke with him earlier today! He should still be out there somewhere!" Zheng Ye held onto the hope that Zheng Weimin had listened to his advice to go into hiding.

"I want the bastard who did this to be found!"

"Rest assured, Mister Zheng. We will use all of our resources to find the culprit. If there is some madman with a weapon that can cause this much destruction out there, we must catch him and seize the weapon at all cost."

After hanging up, Zheng Ye stared at the television with an ugly expression on his face.

Sometime later, he opened his laptop and started a video call with Bai Mengyao.

"What do you want, Zheng Ye?" Bai Mengyao asked him in an annoyed manner, unaware of the situation yet.

"Y-You bastard! Is this your work?! Did you attack my Zheng Family just now?!"

"Huh? What the fuck are you talking about?"

"Turn on the television and see for yourself!" Zheng Ye shouted.

Bai Mengyao recalled a similar situation happening not long ago, but the roles were reversed this time around.

"Holy shit! What happened here?!" Bai Mengyao was terrified by what he saw on the television.

"Wait! You think my Bai Family has something to do with the news?! That's outrageous! Even more outrageous than the shooting today!"

"It's the truth, isn't it?! My Zheng Family got attacked right after you threatened to attack us! There's no way this could be a coincidence!" Zheng Ye roared.

"Are you out of your mind?! You think my Bai Family is capable of this?! There should be a limit to your imagination! Whatever caused this is obviously not human!"

While Zheng Ye and Bai Mengyao argued back and forth, Yuan and White Lotus returned to the hotel.

"Yuan! Are you okay?!" Chu Liuxiang rushed to his side the moment she saw him enter the room.

"Yes, I am fine." He nodded.

"What happened? Did you find any evidence?" Meixiu asked him.

"Yes, Zheng Weimin confessed to hiring the assassins this morning. However, he didn't tell us how to contact the assassins, so we're not completely safe yet, and I won't rest until I find the bastards that shot at us." Yuan said.

"I see... What about Zheng Weimin?"

"I killed him. I didn't want to risk having him come after us again in the future. I'm sorry if my decision disappointed you."

"No, I understand why you did it, and I don't blame you. I'm sorry for making you bear everything for us..."

"It's fine." Yuan shook his head.

After a moment of silence, Chu Liuxiang suddenly spoke, "By the way... Your eyes... They're red."

"Yes. I have somehow regained my vision, so I can see again now." Yuan finally revealed the truth to them.

"What! No way! Really?!" Chu Liuxiang exploded with excitement.

"I'm serious." He nodded with a gentle smile on his face.

"To think this would happen right before Yu Rou's birthday... This is going to be an even bigger surprise than the concert." Meixiu smiled.

"Indeed. That's why I must take care of these assassins before then. I want the birthday surprise to be perfect."

White Lotus entered the room sometime later and said, "Yuan, I had the experts look into Zheng Weimin's cell phone and laptop, and they found a phone number and address that might allow us to contact the assassins."

"Perfect."

Yuan turned to look at Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang and said to them, "I will finish everything this time."

"Stay safe. They're dangerous enough to shoot us in broad daylight."
Meixiu said.

Yuan chuckled, "I doubt it'll be any more dangerous than what I have already experienced at the Zheng Family."

After Yuan left with White Lotus, Chu Liuxiang decided to relax a little and open the television that happened to be on a news channel.

"M-Meixiu... Look at this..." Chu Liuxiang called for her.

"My god... Wait... this happened only half an hour ago?" Meixiu swallowed nervously and turned to look at the door that Yuan just left from.

"You think he's responsible for this?"

Meixiu smiled and said, "If anyone is capable of doing this, it could only be him."

Chapter 969 - Locating the Assassins

Chapter 969 - Locating the Assassins

After leaving the room with White Lotus, Yuan followed her to another room where the experts were inspecting Zheng Weimin's equipment.

"So this is the phone number that might help us contact the assassins, and this location appears to be a meeting point."

"Can you track the phone number?" White Lotus asked.

"We can try, but we'll have to call them first." The expert said.

"I'll call them." Yuan suddenly said.

"What about your backup story?" White Lotus asked.

"I already have one in mind."

"All right. Then let us set up the tracker first." The expert said.

Half an hour later, the expert handed Yuan a specialized cell phone.

"We'll begin the tracking as soon as they pick up the phone. Try to stall them for as long as you can."

Yuan nodded and called the phone number.

After a couple of rings, someone picked up the number and spoke in a cold voice, "Password?"

White Lotus and the experts were listening to the phone call as well, so they immediately frowned upon hearing about a password for the first time.

However, Yuan calmly responded, "Fuck your password. I need a bastard killed. 100 million."

White Lotus turned to look at Yuan with wide eyes.

'He's going to order a hit?!' she cried inwardly.

The person on the other side of the call remained silent for several moments before responding, "I'm sorry, but you have the wrong number."

"Hang up on me and I will call another number, and I will add you bastards to my kill list."

"..."

"Who told you about this phone number?"

"Are you fuckers investigators or mercenaries? If you keep wasting my precious time, I will let the person who recommended me know of your trash service."

After another moment of silence, the person spoke, "Give me a name."

Yuan took a deep but silent breath before speaking, "Yu Yong, he's the head of a major entertainment company that focuses on music."

White Lotus' jaw dropped after hearing this familiar name. After researching Yu Tian's background, she learned of his adoptive parents, Yu Yong and Tang Lee.

'He's putting a hit on his adoptive father?!'

A few moments of silence later, the man behind the phone spoke, "He's a big name. It'll cost you more than 100 million if you want his head."

"Give me a number." Yuan calmly said.

"Five hundred."

"That's a hefty amount. What if you fail?"

"There's no such thing as a perfect hit. However, once we put a target on someone, we will make sure it is a success no matter how many times we fail."

"Very well. I'll pay that amount."

"I will now give you an account number. You have 24 hours to make the payment."

After giving Yuan the account number, the man continued, "Once we see the payment, we will give you a call back. We'll make the real arrangements then."

Yuan then spoke in a cold voice, "Just so you know. I may trust my friend, but I don't trust your service yet. If you dare to scam me, I will destroy your entire organization."

The man laughed out loud, "I welcome you to try even though we won't scam you."

Yuan looked at the experts in the room for their signal.

The expert nodded his head and gave Yuan a thumbs up.

"Then I will see you soon."

After hanging up the call, Yuan went to see the results.

"Although we were able to track the call to their location, we were unable to pinpoint the exact location."

"Just give me the general location and I will find them myself." Yuan said.

"It's about a four hour drive from this place, right around here." The expert showed him the map and the general location of the call.

"I understand. I will go there right away." Yuan nodded.

"Should I come with you again?" White Lotus asked him.

"No, I will be fine by myself. I don't want to endanger you."

"All right... Stay safe."

Yuan left the hotel by himself shortly after and flew towards the location of the assassins.

He decided to fly using the Empyrean Overlord since it was much faster and he could use it for longer.

An hour later, Yuan arrived at the location on the map.

However, there were nothing but trees at his location.

When Yuan couldn't see anything out of the ordinary with his eyes, he decided to use his divine sense.

After a few minutes of searching, he noticed some footprints, which he followed to a hidden entrance that appeared to lead underground.

After taking a moment to look for traps, Yuan landed in front of the entrance, and without any hesitation, he yanked the metal door open with his bare hands.

Alarms began blaring inside the bunker, but Yuan ignored it and headed straight for the room with the most people.

However, he was quickly stopped by people wielding heavy firearms.

"Y-You! What are you doing here?!" The people that stopped him appeared to recognize his face.

"Hey, I'm here to repay the favor. If you lead me to the bastards who shot at me and my friends today, I will let you live." Yuan said to them in a calm voice.

"In your fucking dreams! Now die!"

They opened fire the following moment.

However, as usual, Yuan stopped the bullets with his spiritual energy before they could even reach him.

"Is it that fun to shoot at people? It's all you guys ever do. Let me give it a try." Yuan casually flicked his arm, sending the bullets that he'd caught straight back to the shooters but at an even faster speed.

"Ah!"

The six people there collapsed the following moment with holes all over their corpses.

"How boring." Yuan shook his head and continued making his way deeper inside the bunker.

He would encounter more people with guns, and he would always give them a chance to tell him what he wanted to know in exchange for their lives.

Unfortunately, they would all respond with bullets instead of words.

In the end, Yuan had to kill every person he came across until he reached the lowest part of the bunker, where a massive metal door blocked his path.

Chapter 970 - Locating the Assassins (2)

Chapter 970 - Locating the Assassins (2)

When Yuan reached this metal door that was built to withstand even nuclear weapons, a voice resounded from the speakers in the hallway.

"I fully understand why we were unable to kill you today, you fucking monster. We should've asked for way more money when we accepted the request to kill you." A familiar voice resounded.

Yuan recognized this voice to be the same as the person he spoke to on the phone today.

"You'll need more than guns to kill me." Yuan casually said.

"Anyways, why don't you open the door and let me in? It'll be a whole lot messier if I have to force my way inside."

"Hahaha! Go ahead and break this door if you can! This place was created to withstand even nuclear weapons!"

"Is that so?" Yuan sighed.

He then asked, "Before I do so, I have a question. The bastards that shot at me today. Are they inside with you?"

"I see! So you're looking for the squad responsible for the incident today. Unfortunately, you won't find them here— because they're currently on their way to the White Lotus Hotel!"

"Furthermore, they will kill anyone in that hotel until they find you! However, since you're obviously not there, that means everyone in that hotel will be dead soon!"

After learning this information, Yuan started preparing for the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike.

"Hey, do you remember our call earlier?"

"Huh? What are you talking about?"

"Yu Yong. I was the one who called you just now."

"So you tracked the phone call, huh. Not bad. I am impressed by the one who managed to track us despite all of the security we had."

"You welcomed me to try and destroy your organization. I will be fulfilling your desire now."

"Hahaha! And how are you going to do that?! With that sword in your hand?! In case you missed it, not even nuclear weapons can destroy this place, much less a sword! I have already called for reinforcements, too! They will be swarming this place soon!"

"Whether it will work or not, we'll know soon enough."

Once he'd gathered enough spiritual energy, Yuan released the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike directly at the door.

The ground immediately shook, and the people inside the sealed room felt as though they'd been struck by a meteorite.

A few moments later, Yuan looked at the results.

All of the dirt and materials built around the room had completely vanished, revealing the bunker to the open sky.

However, the room itself was still there.

With that being said, it had sustained heavy damage, and major cracks could be seen around this room that was basically a large metal box.

"W-What the fuck just happened?!" The people in the room were baffled by what they'd just experienced, and they were terrified when they saw the cracks in the walls.

"Wow, you actually survived. I'm genuinely impressed."

The people inside the room could hear Yuan's voice through the cracks on the walls.

"However, it doesn't look like it will be able to survive another one."

"W-Wait!" The familiar voice resounded again, but it sounded much more nervous this time.

"L-Let's talk about this! What do you want?!"

"I want the bastards currently heading to the White Lotus Hotel. Give them to me and I will spare your lives." Yuan said.

"I understand! I will immediately command them to return!"

The man retrieved his cell phone and ordered the squad to return.

"It's been done! They have halted their mission and are currently on their way back here! They should arrive in about three hours!"

"And you expect me to just believe you?"

"I swear on my ancestors' grave that I am telling the truth!" The man said.

Yuan suddenly retrieved a cell phone and called Meixiu.

After explaining the situation to her, he said, "I want you guys to evacuate the hotel. If anything happens there, I want to know."

"I understand. I will call you back once we evacuate."

About half an hour later, Meixiu called him back and said, "We've evacuated to another location. White Lotus left most of her guards behind to protect the hotel, and she's even called in reinforcements. They will contact us if anything happens."

"Thank you. I should return in about four hours if everything goes smoothly."

"Okay."

After hanging up, Yuan proceeded to stand in front of the metal box like a guard, patiently waiting for the assassins to return.

The people inside the metal box wanted to escape, but none of them dared to leave the room, and there was only a single way out of there—the door that was being guarded by Yuan.

Sometime later, the man's voice resounded again, "I-It was you! You're the one responsible for what happened to the Zheng Family today! You're the 'unknown weapon of mass destruction'!"

However, Yuan denied such claims.

"I have no idea what you're talking about."

The people inside the room were well aware that Yuan was lying, but they didn't dare to push their luck and continue to accuse him.

About two and a half hours later, Yuan could see five people approaching the destroyed bunker with his divine sense.

"W-What the fuck happened here?!"

"My god! It's like someone had dropped a nuke on this place!"

"Shit! This is a trap!"

This group of people tried to run away when they realized their situation, but they didn't get very far before Yuan descended from the sky, blocking

their path.

"Why don't you all stay still for a moment? If you try to run, I will immediately kill you." Yuan summoned the Starry Abyss and removed its invisibility, letting it fly around the group to threaten them.

Meanwhile, Yuan faced the bunker and released another Heaven Splitting Sword Strike, completely erasing everything this time.

"Sorry, but I lied when I said that I would let you all live." Yuan mumbled towards the direction of the bunker— at least where it used to exist.

After cleaning up what's left of the bunker and everyone in it, Yuan turned to look at the group of five assassins with a cold gaze, who were terrified out of their minds after what they'd just witnessed.

"It's so nice to see you all again. I have been anticipating this reunion for a while now." Yuan said to them with a gentle smile on his face that looked incredibly devilish to the group.

Chapter 971 - I Will See You in Hell!

Chapter 971 - I Will See You in Hell!

"W-What are you going to do to us, you monster!?" One of the assassins there used all of his courage to shout out loud.

"Nothing much. I am just going to punish you all a little for your actions." Yuan calmly said.

He suddenly flicked his sleeves, immediately severing the arms of one of the assassins there.

"A-Aaaah! My arms!" The assassin screamed in a terrified voice as blood sprayed from his wounds.

"It's just your arms, what's the big deal? I'll give you something else to scream about."

Whoosh!

The Emyrean Overlord moved in a speed that none of the assassins there could see with their bare eyes, and before they realized, Yuan severed that assassin's legs.

The assassin fell to the ground and screamed in horror as he laid around his own severed limbs.

The other four assassins gasped in shock. The scene before their eyes looked like it came straight out of a horror movie.

One of them couldn't endure it any longer and started running around.

"Where do you think you're going?" Yuan's voice resounded as the Starry Abyss caught up with the runner almost immediately.

"Aaaaah!" A painful scream echoed as the Starry Abyss severed the runner's legs.

However, the assassin did not give up and started crawling with his arms.

Unfortunately, he did not go very far as his arms were severed as well.

When the other remaining three assassins saw the result of running away, they all gave up the thought and resigned their lives to fate.

"If you're going to kill us, hurry up and do it. Is there a need to humiliate—torture us?!" One of them suddenly said.

"Need? Of course not. However, I want to— just like how you all decided to kill me."

"B-But that was our job! Someone had put a hit on you! If you're going to blame someone, blame that person!"

"Don't worry, I have already dealt with Zheng Weimin. He's currently waiting for the rest of you in hell. And you can only blame yourself for choosing such a job."

"Die!"

One of them suddenly pulled out a pistol and aimed it at Yuan's head before shooting it.

A 9mm bullet flew toward his face the next moment, but it stopped an inch from his head.

The assassin was in disbelief, but he continued to pull the trigger until he emptied the magazine.

A little over a dozen bullets hovered in front of Yuan's face, but he didn't seem to be concerned, almost as though he had expected it.

"If you're going to come at me, you would have a better chance with a knife than a gun." Yuan glanced at the assassin who shot at him before returning the bullets to its rightful owner.

"Ahhhh!"

The bullets struck all of the assassin's vital parts, paralyzing his body almost instantly.

"Don't worry, you'll bleed to death just like the other two."

Yuan turned to look at the two remaining assassins.

One of them was a bulky middle-aged man and the other was a middle-aged woman.

"P-Please! Spare my life! I will do anything you want! To tell you the truth I am still a virgin! I will let you be my f—" The woman started pleading for her life by offering her body, but Yuan swung the Empyrean Overlord before she could finish, sending her head flying into the air.

"How vile." Yuan muttered in a low voice afterward.

Blood sprayed everywhere, but Yuan covered his body with his spiritual energy.

"It's just you now, huh? Any last words?" Yuan asked the remaining assassin.

"Go fuck yourself. It's a pity that we couldn't kill you or those sluts with you today." The middle-aged man spat at Yuan.

"Is that so?"

Suddenly, the sound of police sirens could be heard approaching their location.

"Looks like it's over for you too." The assassin laughed out loud.

Yuan suddenly smiled and said, "Why don't you see for yourself if that will be the case?"

Before the middle-aged man could even react, Yuan plunged the Empyrean Overlord into his body, skewering it.

The man's eyes widened with shock, but he was not dead yet.

The following moment, he watched as Yuan flew into the sky with him.

Once they were above the clouds, Yuan said to him, "If you survive this fall, I'll let you live."

"You demon..." The man managed to smile despite his hopeless situation.

Yuan retrieved the Empyrean Overlord back inside his body, letting the man fall.

"I will see you in hell, you monster!" The man laughed madly as he fell to his death, which was witnessed by the police and investigators that had just arrived at the bloody scene.

Yuan made his way back to the hotel under the night sky as the police investigated the chaos he'd left behind.

"What on earth is happening in this city? The unknown weapon has been used again, and there are even five brutally mutilated corpses. Are we really dealing with a human here?"

The investigators were baffled by what they found at the crime scene.

"Actually, it appears that the unknown weapon had been used two times in this place."

"What?! How can such a powerful weapon be used so frequently?! This situation is more dire than we initially thought!"

"Just what is the motive of the person or entity behind this?"

"What about these people? They appeared to have been cut by something exceedingly sharp."

"Have you identified them yet?"

"No, none of them had any form of identification. Furthermore, we found weapons hidden on their bodies. They're probably mercenaries—the kind that would do any kind of work as long as they are paid enough."

Sometime later, one of the investigators there found the black van used in the shooting nearby.

"With this new evidence, there's a good chance that these guys were the ones behind the shooting this afternoon. We just need to wait for confirmation from the guys at analysis."

"The person responsible for killing them... The wounds are too brutal, which suggests vengeance."

"Vengeance, huh? It would be for the best if that were the case..." The investigators there sighed.

Chapter 972 - A Big Mistake

Chapter 972 - A Big Mistake

After returning to the hotel, Yuan went to look for the others, who had been waiting anxiously for his return.

"Yuan! You're back!" Chu Liuxiang said.

"Are you hurt anywhere?" Meixiu asked him.

"No, I am perfectly fine." He shook his head.

"Welcome back." White Lotus said to him.

"By the way, your deeds are already on the news." She pointed at the television that was already talking about the chaos he'd caused outside the city.

[The unknown weapon of mass destruction has been used again! Furthermore, the authorities have found the culprits behind the shooting this afternoon at...]

"You know, many people have already left the city because of this commotion, and there will be even more leaving tomorrow when they wake up to see the news. I've even received many calls from those at the faction today, all of them are asking to relocate the faction temporarily. They're all scared of that technique of yours— scared that you might release this 'weapon of mass destruction' in the city."

"Sorry, I wanted to resolve this without using the technique, but that wasn't possible. I even had to use it twice." Yuan sighed.

"Let's just hope that there will be an audience for the concert tomorrow. However, with all of the chaos today, I'm afraid that will be quite hard."

"It's fine. The only audience I need is my sister, Yu Rou." Yuan smiled.

"So what's going to happen now?" Chu Liuxiang asked a moment later.

"Are we just going to pretend like nothing happened? There's a lot of people looking for you, right?"

"It'll be fine. They will eventually give up when they cannot find anything. If they find me, we will deal with it at that time." Yuan said.

"Don't worry, the Bai Family will help you keep your secret. Even if your secret is revealed, we have our methods to protect you." White Lotus said.

"Thank you."

Sometime later, Yuan said to them, "Let's go to sleep. I need some rest after what happened today."

"Good night."

After returning to his room, Yuan closed the lights and laid on the bed, but he did not go to sleep immediately.

'I have killed a lot of people today. Even though it's not my first time killing someone since Cultivation Online is also a real world, it feels unnatural to stain my hands with blood in this world.'

'Yu Rou... What will she think when she learns that her brother has turned into a killer?'

Yuan slowly fell asleep as he thought about the day that felt longer than usual.

While he slept, dreams that felt incredibly surreal started appearing.

Inside his dream, he was surrounded by a sea of flames and rivers of blood.

The sky was dark and red, and the whole world appeared to be dyed in black and red.

'This is... the Evil God's memories?' Yuan looked around the gruesome scenery with a slight frown on his face.

All of the buildings were on fire, and there were corpses littered on every street.

"Did the Evil God— I really do all of this?" Yuan mumbled in a low voice.

"You monster! You're responsible for this!"

A desperate cry suddenly resounded behind him.

He turned around to see a middle-aged man holding onto a child, but the child was missing half of his body.

Tears made out of blood flowed from this man's eyes as he roared, "If only you didn't exist, none of this would've happened! You killed all of them! I hope you die!"

However, Yuan couldn't feel any emotions when looking at this middle-aged man who was filled with despair and anger.

His heart was as still and as cold as a block of ice.

Suddenly, Yuan turned to look at the sky, where hundreds of people wearing silver armor could be seen approaching him with killing intent.

When Yuan saw these soldiers, his empty heart started burning with unimaginable rage and bloodlust, and without waiting any longer, he leaped into the air, flying towards these soldiers.

"Surrender yourself already, Evil God! You won't win this war!" One of the soldiers shouted.

"Hahaha! Whether I win this war or not is not something for you to decide!" Yuan laughed like a madman as he used some kind of technique to kill

many of the soldiers in one go.

"Are you seriously going to defy the Celestial Emperor— the Heavens?! You're making a big mistake!"

"A mistake? If we're going to talk about mistakes, then let's start with the biggest one in the room— offending me! Hahaha!"

In just mere moments, the Evil God killed all of the soldiers there.

After killing the soldiers, the Evil God lifted his head and released a powerful roar that shook the world.

The roar was so powerful that it startled Yuan awake from his sleep.

"Damn... The Evil God is even more dangerous than I initially thought... Just what caused him to go on such a rampage? Did the Celestial Emperor kill his love or something?" Yuan mumbled in a low voice.

"I am still nowhere close to absorbing all of the Divine Paragon's memories, yet the Evil God's memories are already leaking. I might really go insane if I have to handle the memories of two Immortals at once."

After waking up, Yuan found it hard to go back to sleep, and his body was soaked in sweat.

He decided to take a shower a few moments later to clean his body and clear his mind.

After the shower, Yuan went to look at himself in the mirror, and to his surprise, his red eyes had disappeared. However, he was still able to see using his eyes.

'Just what on earth is going on with my body? There are too many questions and not enough answers...'

Yuan decided to spend the rest of the night cultivating since he couldn't go back to sleep.

Meanwhile, inside her room, Meixiu was deciding whether to answer her cell phone that has been ringing for a while now.

After pondering for a few minutes, Meixiu sighed and picked up the cell phone before dialing Yu Rou.

"Hello? Sorry, I was preparing breakfast just now, so I couldn't pick up the phone."

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Chapter 973 - Hospitalized

Chapter 973 - Hospitalized

"Hey, Meixiu! Sorry for bothering you, but can I speak with my brother? I wanted to wait until tomorrow before I called, but I just cannot wait any longer!" Yu Rou said.

"You sound like you're in a hurry. Did something happen?" Meixiu asked.

"Did you not see the news? Something horrible is happening in my city! I could be dead tomorrow at this rate!"

Of course, Yu Rou was talking about the unknown weapon of mass destruction that has terrorized her city.

"Ah, I know what you're talking about. However, I wouldn't worry too much if I were you." Meixiu said.

"Huh? Why would you say that?"

"If this person really wanted to harm the city, they would've destroyed the city already."

"I just can't help but worry when everyone around me is panicking." Yu Rou sighed.

"Anyways, you wanted to speak with Yuan, right? I'm sorry, but that's not possible right now." Meixiu said a moment later.

"Huh? Why not?"

"Well... To tell you the truth, he told me to not tell you since he doesn't want to worry you, but since it's your birthday tomorrow and the truth will eventually be known... Yuan is currently hospitalized."

"HE'S WHAT?!?!!" Yu Rou screamed after hearing this unexpected news.

"What happened to him?! Is he okay?!"

"He got injured during training. It's only a few broken bones, so there's no need to worry."

"That sounds horrible! A few broken bones?! That's very serious! What if he cripples himself again?! He's just got his body back!" Yu Rou exclaimed.

"The doctors said that he'll make a full recovery in a few days." Although Meixiu felt bad about lying to Yu Rou like this, she couldn't let Yuan's hard work go to waste.

"Haaa..." Yu Rou suddenly sighed through the phone.

"I was really looking forward to speaking with Brother on my birthday..."

"Don't worry, I will make sure that you'll still get to speak with him tomorrow." Meixiu said.

"Thank you, Meixiu, but don't force him if he isn't in the condition."

"Anyways, I am going to sleep now. I have something important that I must attend tomorrow morning."

"Goodnight." Meixiu said to her before hanging up.

"Is everything okay?" Xia Jingyi asked Yu Rou after she put down her phone.

"That stupid brother of mine got himself hospitalized right before my birthday! Can you believe it?!" Yu Rou complained.

Xia Jingyi covered her mouth and gasped, "Oh my... I hope he's okay."

"He broke some bones, but he'll make a full recovery."

"Brother is such an idiot. He should treat his body with more care and respect, especially considering how he's already been crippled once before. I'm going to give him a piece of my mind when I go on vacation next month!"

"Anyways, let's go to sleep. We have an important meeting tomorrow according to the Seniors."

"All right. Goodnight, Yu Rou."

"Night."

The following morning, after their morning routine, Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi gathered outside the faction.

"Good morning, Elder Yin." Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi greeted the old woman that was there before them.

"Are you two ready to leave?" Elder Yin asked them.

"Yes, we are."

"Good."

Once they were in the car, Yu Rou asked, "Elder Yin, where are you taking us today?"

"To tell you the truth, I also have no idea. White Lotus said she was in trouble and needed some extra hands, so we picked a couple of disciples to help her." Elder Yin shrugged.

Yu Rou raised her eyebrows.

She looked around the car and asked, "Where are the others?"

"They went ahead since the seats were filled."

"I see..."

Yu Rou sighed inwardly, 'Why do I have to do such chores on my birthday? It's even my day off! Can this day get any worse?'

Meanwhile, Yuan and the others prepared for the surprise.

The concert was to be performed in the city square, one of the busiest places in the city.

"Which idiot decided to do a concert at such a time? Aren't they aware of the danger in this city?"

Most of the streets were empty because everyone decided to stay at home for the next few days due to the recent commotion.

However, the roads were packed with cars because people were trying to leave the city.

With that being said, there was a crowd of people in front of the stage, and most of these people were sent by the Cultivators' Association.

In fact, even the Chairman himself was present.

Even though Yuan had only asked him to prepare the concert, Chairman Lee decided to participate in it as well.

The rest of the people in the crowd were people from the Bai Family, led by Bai Mengyao himself.

After hearing about the concert, Bai Mengyao immediately flew to this city. Of course, he had other intentions.

"Yuan, can I take a moment of your time to introduce my father to you? He came all the way here from another city to meet you." White Lotus asked him after they arrived at the city square.

"Sure." He agreed.

Sometime later, Yuan met with White Lotus' father, Bai Mengyao.

"It's an honor to finally meet the famous Player Yuan. I am Bai Mengyao, White Lotus' father." Bai Mengyao extended his hand for a handshake.

"Just call me Yuan." He accepted the handshake.

"After hearing from my daughter that you'd saved her life, I have been dying to repay the favor. Please, if you need anything, just let me know." Bai Mengyao shook his hands vigorously.

Yuan smiled and said, "Don't even mention it. I am the one who owes White Lotus, who has been a great assistance and friend for the last two days."

"That's great to hear, but my offer will remain. If you ever have troubles, you can contact me or my daughter. We may not be the strongest family in the Legacy Ranking, but we're up there."

"I understand."

After chatting with White Lotus' father for some time, Chairman Lee approached him and started another conversation.

When the crowd there noticed how respectful Chairman Lee and Bai Mengyao were acting towards Yuan, they became interested in his identity.

Of course, besides some people there, the majority of people in the crowd were unaware of Yuan's true identity.

Chapter 974 - My Name is Yu Tian

Chapter 974 - My Name is Yu Tian

"Yuan, we have some trouble." White Lotus suddenly approached him.

"What happened?"

"Well, it's nothing serious, but Yu Rou and her friend are currently stuck in traffic, so they'll be late."

"Oh, all right. It's fine. I can wait."

Sometime later, Meixiu approached him and said, "Yuan, I should've told you this earlier, but..."

She proceeded to explain to him what she'd told Yu Rou last night when she called.

"You told her that I was hospitalized from training?" Yuan couldn't help but laugh at this news.

"She's probably going to be angry once she realizes that I'd lied to her."

"I'm sure she'll understand your intentions. Also, she'll probably forget about it after the concert." Yuan chuckled.

Meanwhile, somewhere inside the city, Yu Rou and the others were stuck in traffic.

"Are the roads usually this busy in the city?" Yu Rou asked, as this is her first time leaving the faction since her arrival several months ago.

"No, not at all. These people are probably fleeing the city." Elder Yin said.

"I would be fleeing the city too if I wasn't living outside the city." Yu Rou smiled.

About half an hour later, Elder Yin received a call from White Lotus.

"Yes, we're almost there. In fact, we can probably walk the rest of the distance."

"Okay, I understand."

After hanging up, Elder Yin said to Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi, "We're going to be walking the rest of the way since we're already half an hour late."

Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi nodded their heads, and the three of them left the car shortly after.

After another ten minutes, they arrived at the city square, where a crowd of people could be seen sitting in front of what appeared to be a portable stage.

"What is going on here?" Yu Rou mumbled in a low voice.

"It looks like a concert... There's even a piano on the stage." Xia Jingyi said.

"A concert at this time? Who would be stupid enough to do something like this?" Yu Rou shook her head.

However, Elder Yin suddenly started leading them toward the concert.

"Elder Yin? Should we really waste our time here?" Yu Rou couldn't help but ask.

After all, their faction leader was waiting for their arrival.

However, Elder Yin didn't say anything to her, so they just stood there in silence.

Suddenly, a person walked onto the stage with a microphone in his hands.

Yu Rou didn't immediately recognize the person on the stage, but when she took a closer look at his face, her eyes widened with shock.

"N-No way..." She muttered in a low voice that was filled with disbelief.

Yuan stopped at the center of the stage and lifted the microphone closer to his mouth.

"Thank you all for coming today. My name is Yu Tian. Some of you might recognize my name because I used to be a professional musician, but I was forced to retire early due to some misfortune. However, I am proud to announce that I have fully recovered!"

"Yu Tian? I recognize him! He's that child prodigy who took the world by storm with his music! I remember going to his concert once! It cost me an arm and leg, but it was definitely worth it!"

"Now that you mention it, I have heard of his name before, too!"

"Y-Yu Rou... Isn't that your..." Xia Jingyi turned to look at Yu Rou, who was standing there with a baffled look on her face.

"Brother...?" Yu Rou's eyes began turning moist, and before long, tears appeared at the edge of her eyes.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan continued to speak while his gaze looked directly at Yu Rou, "Although I have already retired from my career as a professional musician, I have decided to temporarily come out of retirement just for today as a special occasion to celebrate my precious little sister's 17th birthday."

Yuan walked to the piano and took a seat.

After taking a deep breath, his hands started dancing on the piano's keyboard, officially starting his concert.

The audience were immediately enchanted by the heavenly music produced by Yuan's fingers, feeling as though they were being led above the skies by his music notes.

Of course, Yuan wanted this concert to be as realistic and official as possible, so he made sure to have it broadcasted live on television.

Meanwhile, at the Yu Family.

Yu Yong, who was cultivating in silence inside his room, suddenly opened his eyes when all four of his cell phones began ringing almost at the same time.

"This is Yu Yong." He randomly picked one and answered it.

"Yu Yong! You bastard! How long have you been keeping this secret for?!" His colleague's voice resounded.

"Huh? What are you talking about?"

"You're still acting like you don't know anything? Spare me from your humor!"

"I-I'm really confused right now. What are you talking about?" Yu Yong was genuinely puzzled by the situation.

"Turn on your television and go to any music channel!"

Yu Yong immediately turned on the television in his room.

After changing the channel, he could see the live broadcast for a certain public concert.

Yu Yong didn't recognize the person sitting behind the piano at first, but when the camera zoomed in on Yuan's face, Yu Yong quickly realize who he had been staring at, and he cried out loud, "What the fuck is going on?!"

"I should be asking you that, Yu Yong! When did your son, Yu Tian, recover?! You should've told us about it the moment it happened! Do you

have any idea how much he means to the music industry and our wallets?! And what's with this shabby-looking concert?! This is his first concert in a decade! You should've prepared something more grand! All of our investors are fuming with anger as we speak!"

However, Yu Yong was so shocked by what he was seeing that he didn't even hear what had been said through the phone.

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Chapter 975 - Happy Birthday

Chapter 975 - Happy Birthday

"Darling! Take a look at the television!" Tang Lee burst into Yu Yong's room shortly after he found out about Yuan's concert.

"I am watching it now! How did this happen?!" Yu Yong gritted his teeth in frustration.

"I don't know, but our investors are contacting us from all directions! They think we're behind this, and they're super angry right now! We need to do something!"

"Of course they are angry! I would be angry too! His return after a decade could've brought us hundreds of millions! However, he wasted it on this shitty concert!" Yu Yong roared.

"Damn it! What should we do?! That bastard seems to have made a recovery! However, we have already kicked him out of the family! If only we had waited for a couple more months, none of this would be happening!"

"Calm down, it's not over yet." Tang Lee said with a cold smile on her face.

"In case you forgot, we still have his contract, and even though we kicked him out, he is still legally part of our family. We'll force him back into our grasp no matter what it takes! I'll go call Meifeng and our lawyers right now!"

Meanwhile, at the city square, the crowd in front of Yuan's concert would grow bigger as time passed.

The people that had been too terrified to leave their homes suddenly decided to witness this performance with their eyes even at the cost of their lives.

By the third song, the entire square was filled with people, and even the people trying to leave the city halted their movements, which clogged up the traffic even more, putting it to a complete halt.

"That young man on the stage looks very familiar! Where have I seen him before?"

"That's that child prodigy Yu Tian!"

"Oh! I remember now! The one that suddenly disappeared a decade ago? I thought he had died!"

"Apparently, he had been suffering from an illness until recently."

"Does this mean he'll return to playing the instruments?! I'll have to attend one of them even if it costs me my entire fortune!"

"Aren't you at one right now? And it's even free!"

"Heavens! I didn't think he could improve, but it sounds even better than I remember!"

Yuan decided to play a total of 17 songs because it was Yu Rou's 17th birthday.

At the end of his last song, Yuan stood up and walked to the microphone before speaking, "Happy birthday, Yu Rou."

The crowd erupted with cheers afterward.

However, there was one person that wasn't cheering, and that was Yu Rou, who was too busy wiping her tears.

Sometime later, Yuan jumped off the stage and began walking into the crowd.

The people there quickly made a path for him until he reached Yu Rou.

"Surprise." Yuan said to her with a bright smile on his face.

"You idiot... How dare you make me cry on my birthday... and in front of so many people..." Yu Rou cried.

Yuan opened his arms, gesturing for a hug.

Yu Rou immediately jumped into his embrace and cried on his chest until she could no longer produce tears and Yuan's clothes were soaking wet.

"Brother... I love you..." Yu Rou mumbled afterward.

"Yes, I love you too." Yuan smiled as he patted her head.

Sometime later, Yuan returned to the stage and said to the audience, "Thank you all for coming to my concert today. Although I will not be returning to my old career as a musician because I found something else I want to chase, I will not give up on music, so you can expect to see me again in the future!"

The audience refused to leave even after the concert was over, and many of them had questions for him.

However, the Bai Family and the Cultivators' Association worked together to keep them from swarming Yuan.

"T-That was an amazing concert, Senior Yu..." Xia Jingyi said.

"Senior Yu? Just call me Yuan. Yu Rou already told you about it, right?"

"Y-Yes... But are you sure? There's still so many people around us..." Xia Jingyi looked around in a nervous manner.

When Yu Rou revealed to Xia Jingyi that her Brother, Yu Tian, was actually Player Yuan, Xia Jingyi was so shocked that she fell unconscious for an entire minute.

"I don't care about hiding my identity anymore so it's fine." Yuan smiled.

"B-By the way, Brother... Your eyes... Have your vision returned?" Yu Rou finally got to ask him.

"Yes, I have regained my vision. In fact, I regained it just yesterday." He nodded.

"That's amazing! How did it return? Did you do anything special?"

"No, it just came back suddenly, just like how my body suddenly started working again."

"Anyways, let's stop talking about me. It's your birthday, after all. Is there anything you want to do?" Yuan asked her.

Yu Rou pondered for a moment before shaking her head, "Not really. I had planned on relaxing in my room and spending most of the day talking to you on the phone, but Meixiu told me that you'd been hospitalized."

"S-Sorry... I didn't want to ruin the surprise..." Meixiu said with a stiff smile on her face.

"Hello, Yu Rou! It's been a while!" Chu Liuxiang suddenly stepped forward with a smile on her face.

"Lulu! You're here too!?"

"Of course. And happy birthday."

"Thank you."

"Ah, I didn't bring any presents with me this year, but next year, I will definitely get you something."

"It's fine. I don't care about that." Yu Rou shook her head.

"Anyways, let's go somewhere quieter. It's too noisy here."

"Sure."

They all made their way to the White Lotus Hotel.

However, before they can even sit down and relax on the peaceful roof, Meixiu suddenly received a phone call from her mother, Meifeng.

"It's my mother. She's probably calling about the concert... Should I answer it?" Meixiu sighed.

"Go ahead. Let's see what she—the Yu Family wants." Yuan nodded with a calm smile on his face.

"Okay."

Meixiu answered the phone the next moment.

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Chapter 976 - What Can a Child Like Him Do to Us?

Chapter 976 - What Can a Child Like Him Do to Us?

"Hello?" Meixiu spoke after answering the phone.

"You can guess why I called you, right?" Meifeng's calm voice resounded through the phone.

"It's about the concert, right?"

"Is the Young Master with you?"

"Yes, he is."

"Can I speak with him?"

Meixiu turned to look at Yuan, who was already gesturing for the phone.

"Hello, Miss Meifeng. It's been a while." Yuan said.

"Young Master... I'm sure you already expected this even before you planned that concert, but the Yu Family is demanding for you to return to the family now that they are aware of your recovery." Meifeng said.

"Yes, I anticipated that something like this would happen. I can even imagine their faces when they realized that I've recovered."

"What are you going to do now? The Yu Family is already in the process of getting you back. Although the Yu Family is not that threatening in terms of

influence, it's their investors that you should be worried about. They won't let you get away so easily."

"And what are they going to do? Force me to play music again?"

"They will most likely threaten you with legal issues and other stuff. If you refuse, they will destroy everything you own and make it so that you won't be able to survive without their help."

"Is that all? That's a lot more boring than what I had in mind." Yuan smiled.

Meifeng was a little baffled by how calm Yuan was acting.

"Young Master..."

"Don't worry, Miss Meifeng. I will willingly come back to the Yu Family later. It's Yu Rou's birthday today, so I am going to spend some time with her. Tell this to the Yu Family."

"Are you really just going to return to the Yu Family? After everything they've done to you?" Meifeng was puzzled again.

"I'm sure they'll be relieved to hear such words, so yes, go ahead and tell them that I will be returning to the Yu Family to work for them again. Anyways, I will talk to you again when I return, Miss Feng."

Yuan hung up the phone after that sentence.

"Y-You're going to go back to the Yu Family?" Yu Rou stared at him with wide eyes.

"Of course not. However, if I don't tell them that, they'll try to mess with us. I'm just buying us some time." Yuan smiled.

"Do you need some help dealing with the Yu Family? My Bai Family can easily crush the Yu Family for you." White Lotus suddenly asked him.

"Thank you for the offer, but this is a family problem that I want to deal with by myself."

"Anyways, let's forget about the Yu Family for now. I want to focus on Yu Rou for today."

"Even if you say that, I don't know what I want to do. I'm satisfied with just spending time with all of you." Yu Rou sighed.

Yuan pondered for a moment before speaking, "Yu Rou, let's go on a quick adventure."

"Where are we going?"

"It doesn't matter." Yuan shook his head.

He then said to Meixiu and the others, "We're going to fly around for a bit."

"Sure." They nodded.

"Huh? Fly?" Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi raised their eyebrows.

Yuan suddenly picked up Yu Rou and carried her like a princess.

"B-Brother!? What are you doing?!" She cried out loud in surprise.

"We're going to go on a little adventure around the city."

And without explaining any further, Yuan flew into the sky.

The others could hear Yu Rou screaming for her life the following moment.

"H-He's flying?!" Xia Jingyi watched their figures disappear into the clouds with a wide mouth.

"It's not your first time flying, so why are you so scared?" Yuan laughed out loud.

"T-That was in Cultivation Online! How are you doing this?!"

"I'm a Spirit Grandmaster."

"No way..."

"Anyways, let's catch up with each other. I am aware that I have been neglecting you for a while now, and I am sorry for that."

Yu Rou sighed, "You don't have to apologize. I have also been busy with my own training, not to mention the difference in our time zone."

The two of them proceeded to tell their own experience for the past few months to each other.

An hour later, Yuan and Yu Rou returned to the hotel, where they continued to chat over some food and tea.

Meanwhile, Meifeng notified the Yu Family of Yuan's decision.

"He agreed to come back to work for us? That was easier than I expected." Yu Yong was dumbfounded after hearing the news.

"This is a little too easy. I think he might be up to something. Let's still prepare just in case." Tang Lee said.

"Of course, but what can a child like him do to us? He's only 18 years old, and he's lived more than half of that life as a cripple. I bet he agreed to come back because he has barely survived the last few months. He will never win against us." Yu Yong laughed out loud.

"Now that he can move again, he has a lot of work to make up for— a decade's worth!" Tang Lee said.

The Yu Family became fully active again in preparation for their future profits.

Later that night, Yuan and the others ate dinner together.

"Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi, the two of you can stay here tonight. We'll all return to the faction tomorrow. However, if you want, you can stay out here with your brother for a few more days." White Lotus said to them.

"Huh? Brother is coming back to the faction with us? I thought males aren't allowed inside." Yu Rou said.

"This is a special occasion." White Lotus smiled.

"Since Brother is coming with us, there's no need to stay here for any longer. And with the recent commotion, I will feel safer at the faction, too." Yu Rou said.

"All right. Then we'll return to the faction tomorrow." White Lotus nodded.

After dinner, Yu Rou suddenly approached Yuan and said, "Brother! I want to sleep with you tonight!"

"Sure." Yuan agreed without any hesitation.

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Chapter 977 - Feelings

Chapter 977 - Feelings

Once all of the lights in the room were shut off, Yuan and Yu Rou entered the bed together.

"How long has it been since we slept together? It's only been several months since you left the Yu Family, but it feels like much longer has passed." Yu Rou suddenly said.

Yuan turned his head sideways to look at her delicate face and smiled, "You have matured a lot since the last time I saw you."

"I had to grow up fast now that I am living alone. Living by yourself isn't easy. I thought that I was ready because I had been able to take care of you for years without much trouble, but I underestimated it. It's actually a lot harder to take care of yourself than to take care of others. Fortunately, Jingyi is there with me, so I am not truly alone."

"And brother, I can also say the same to you. You've changed a lot."

"Well, just like you, I also had to grow up fast."

"I know, but you also seem like a different person." Yu Rou said.

"In a bad sense?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"No, not in a bad sense. Before, even though you are older than me, it kind of felt like I was the older one. However, after spending a day with you, I can finally experience being a little sister again."

"Do you prefer the way I am now, or would you rather the old and naive me?"

Yu Rou pondered for a moment before speaking, "Honestly, I like both versions of you. However, if I had to choose, I would definitely choose the current you."

"Can I ask why?"

However, Yu Rou shook her head in silence.

"That's a secret," she mumbled in a bashful voice.

Due to the darkness in the room, Yu Rou's red face remained hidden.

"I guess everyone has their own secrets." Yuan smiled, not minding it.

After a moment of silence, Yu Rou turned to stare at Yuan's face with a serious expression.

"Brother... I have been wanting to ask you this, but I never got the chance."

"Meixiu... How are things between you and Meixiu right now?"

"Eh?" Yuan was taken aback by this sudden question.

"I mean, the two of you have been living together for a while now, and you even got to spend a few months living together inside a small apartment. As two young adults, you must have made some progress in your relationships, right?!"

"I-I don't get what you're trying to ask..." Yuan pretended to be oblivious.

However, Yu Rou wasn't having any of it and continued, "Don't lie to me, brother."

"Meixiu is a very attractive and beautiful woman, and she has been taking care of you ever since you left the Yu Family. The two of you are even

around the same age. There's no way that you don't have any feelings for her."

"There's really nothing between us, Yu Rou." Yuan showed her a bittersweet smile.

"Brother! I might have believed you if you were still as naive as before, but you're different now! I am also different! I have matured as your sister and as a woman! I can tell that there's something between the two of you!"

Seeing the expression on Yu Rou's face at this moment, Yuan released a low sigh.

"All right, I will tell you the truth. Indeed, Meixiu is an attractive woman. After all, she's managed to charm me."

"I knew it!" Yu Rou exclaimed.

"How far have you gotten with her? Have you confessed yet?!"

Yuan responded with a stiff smile on his face, "Actually... We're already way past that point."

"Huh?" Yu Rou's eyes widened.

"S-So you're already partners? Like the 'boyfriend and girlfriend' kind?"

"Yes." Yuan nodded.

"I-I see... I have to admit... I truly didn't expect this..." she muttered in a dazed voice.

After a long moment of silence, she asked him, "W-What about Lulu? She likes you too, right? What are you going to do about her?"

"A-About that... She's also my partner..."

"WHAT?!" Yu Rou jumped off the bed after hearing this shocking information.

"How can Lulu be your partner when you already have Meixiu as your partner?! D-Don't tell me... You're two-timing them?!"

"What? No! I am not two-timing anyone!" Yuan quickly said.

Not wanting the misunderstanding to deepen any further, he explained to Yu Rou the whole situation.

"Meixiu and Lulu are both my partners, and they are both aware of it. I couldn't just accept one of them and abandon the other, so I decided to accept both of them. They also agreed to this."

Yu Rou's jaw dropped to the floor after learning the truth.

"M-My brother has a harem..." Yu Rou fell to the ground on her knees.

"Yu Rou?! Are you okay?"

"I-I thought I was mature enough to handle the truth, but alas, I have overestimated myself once again..." Yu Rou said to herself in a dispirited voice.

The room fell completely silent afterward.

Many moments later, Yu Rou stood up and said to Yuan, "Brother! I will be right back! Don't you dare leave this room until I come back!"

And without explaining any further, Yu Rou left the room.

Yuan had an idea where Yu Rou went, so he didn't bother chasing after her.

Sometime later, Yu Rou knocked on the door to Meixiu's room.

"Yu Rou? What's the matter? I thought you were going to sleep with Yuan." Meixiu asked her.

"We need to talk!" Yu Rou said as she entered the room.

Meixiu was puzzled by the situation, but she could tell that Yu Rou seemed frustrated at something.

Once she closed the door, Meixiu approached Yu Rou and asked, "What's wrong?"

Yu Rou did not immediately respond and merely silently stared at Meixiu's confused face.

After a moment of silence, she finally spoke, "Meixiu, I know everything. Brother told me the truth about your relationship with him... and Lulu."

"Eh?" Meixiu's eyes widened.

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Chapter 978 - All the Way

Chapter 978 - All the Way

"Don't worry, I'm not angry." Yu Rou said after seeing Meixiu's worried expression.

"You guys wanted to keep it a secret from me because you didn't know how I would react, right? Thank you for your concerns, but I can handle myself."

"However, I would be lying if I said that I am not shocked by the results."

"Anyways, I came here because I have some questions that I can only ask you since it would be too embarrassing to ask my Brother."

"First of all, how long has this been happening?"

Meixiu pondered for a moment before speaking, "Sometime after we moved out of Xia Jingyi's apartment."

"Then my second question... How far have you guys gone?! Have you kissed yet?!" Yu Rou asked in an anxious manner.

Meixiu swallowed nervously.

She didn't dare to respond without thinking about it first, as this could break Yu Rou's spirit.

'Should I lie to her and say that we've only kissed, or should I tell her the truth— that we've gone all the way?'

"You're not going to lie to me again, are you?" Yu Rou suddenly said with narrowed eyes.

"I have forgiven you for lying about my brother being hospitalized, but I won't forgive you if you lie to me this time!"

Seeing Yu Rou's stern face, Meixiu sighed, "We have kissed. In fact, we have already gone all the way."

"W-What?" Yu Rou was taken aback by Meixiu's words

It took her a moment to comprehend the meaning behind Meixiu's words, but when she finally understood the true meaning, Yu Rou's face flushed with redness.

"Y-You've gone all the way?! L-Like... ALL THE WAY?!" Yu Rou wanted confirmation, as she hoped that it was just another misunderstanding.

However, Meixiu said, "Yes, we've gone all the way— we had sex."

Yu Rou started stumbling backward until she fell on the bed, where she would quietly lie down and stare at the ceiling with a dazed look on her face.

After a whole minute of awkward silence, Yu Rou spoke, "Lulu... Did he also do it with her?"

"Yes." Meixiu answered without hesitation.

"I see... So you guys have finally done it. Good for you, Meixiu."

"Huh?" Meixiu raised her eyebrows.

Yu Rou sat on the bed and said, "You've always liked him, right? The only reason you started working for the Yu Family is so that you could be with my brother. Now that your dreams have come true, what are you going to do next?"

"We haven't planned that far yet." Meixiu shook her head.

Yu Rou turned silent again.

"Are you okay, Yu Rou?" Meixiu suddenly asked her.

"What makes you think that I am not okay?" Yu Rou looked at her.

"I mean... You also like him, right?"

"Of course. He's my precious brother."

"You know that's not what I mean." Meixiu said.

A bittersweet smile appeared on Yu Rou's face as she spoke, "Why are you asking me that?"

"Don't you want to be with Yuan? If it's you, I wouldn't mind having you in our family. I think Lulu will also say the same thing." Meixiu said.

"What? Are you crazy? There's no way we can be partners! He's my brother!" Yu Rou exclaimed.

"Yes, but that is only in name. You're not actually blood-related, so there's no problem."

"There's plenty of problems! Although we may not share the same blood, we have lived most of our lives as siblings! He will definitely reject such an idea, and that will destroy our current relationship! I don't want that to happen!"

"Yu Rou..."

"Thank you, Meixiu. I understand your feelings, but you do not need to be concerned about me. Just like how you figured things out with him by yourselves, I am also going to do the same."

"Anyways, it's getting late. I'm going to go to sleep."

Yu Rou left Meixiu's room and returned to Yuan shortly after.

"I didn't think that you'd return." Yuan said to her.

"Why would you think that?" Yu Rou said as she entered the bed.

"You're not angry?"

"What's there to be angry about? I'm only a little frustrated that you tried to hide the truth from me, that's all."

"Sorry."

"Brother, can I hug you?" She suddenly asked.

"Of course."

Yu Rou moved closer to him and treated his body like a hug pillow.

"I'm going to sleep like this. Goodnight."

"Goodnight."

A few minutes later, Yuan could hear Yu Rou sobbing.

However, he decided to not say anything and pretended to be asleep.

Yu Rou also didn't say anything and kept on crying until she fell asleep.

The following morning, they both acted as though last night never happened.

"Good morning." Yu Rou said to him.

"Morning."

After doing their morning routine, Yuan and Yu Rou went to eat breakfast with the others.

Although none of them said anything about last night, Chu Liuxiang, Xia Jingyi, and White Lotus could sense something off about the atmosphere.

In the end, breakfast ended up feeling a little awkward, mostly because it was a little too quiet.

"Are you guys ready to leave? It'll be a two hour ride to the faction." White Lotus asked them.

"Yes, we're ready."

Once everyone was in a car, they started driving towards the Eternal Lotuses' headquarters.

Their journey to the headquarters was as quiet as breakfast, but it lasted twice as long.

It was obvious to Chu Liuxiang and the others that something had happened to the siblings last night, but nobody there dared to ask.

Upon arriving at the Eternal Lotuses' headquarters, White Lotus said, "I should've probably mentioned this before we came here, but I kind of forgot about them. We actually have a few guests staying here at the moment, and they're all looking for you..."

"Me?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"I got ahead of myself after our meeting in Cultivation Online and bragged about it to some people... I'm really sorry! But I didn't tell them anything about our conversations! I swear!" White Lotus lowered her head and apologized.

Yuan smiled and said, "Don't worry about it. I'll entertain them for a bit if they approach me."

"Thank you."

They all entered the Eternal Lotuses' headquarters shortly after.

Chapter 979 - Visiting Eternal Lotuses

Chapter 979 - Visiting Eternal Lotuses

Before entering the Eternal Lotuses' Headquarters, Yuan wore a mask on his face.

"Why are you wearing a mask now?" Yu Rou couldn't help but ask him.

"I don't want to ruin your life in this place. From this point forth, I will be 'Yuan', not Yu Tian." He said.

"I don't care if people find out that you're my brother... In fact, that's something I can brag about."

"I'm only doing this because of the Legacy Families. They're a bunch of annoying people that you don't want to deal with, and I am trying to save you from them."

'A-A bunch of annoying people...' White Lotus sighed inwardly after hearing his words.

As she was from a Legacy Family, she couldn't help but feel like she was part of these annoying people. However, she couldn't refute such claims either, as she found other Legacy Families to be pretty annoying as well.

"Welcome back, Leader Bai, Elder Yin. Welcome to the Eternal Lotuses, Guests." The disciples at the front gate greeted them.

They didn't immediately realize that there was a man amongst their group because Yuan was wearing a mask, and he had long hair tied into a ponytail.

Although his body structure was larger than the ladies there, it wasn't enough to raise any suspicions.

"Is there anything you want to see first, or should I just give you a tour around our faction?" White Lotus asked Yuan after they entered the faction.

"I'll let you decide where we go. I just want to see what Yu Rou's life has been like for the past few months."

"I understand. Then let's do a walkthrough of our disciples' daily routine. There should still be some disciples doing morning training right now."

Yuan nodded, and they proceeded to follow White Lotus around the faction, starting from the area where most disciples go to train.

White Lotus would give them a brief explanation of the place while Yu Rou would recall her experience there.

The disciples there eventually realized that there was a man amongst them, and rumors quickly began to spread like wildfire.

"Did you hear? Senior Bai brought a man into the faction!"

"What! This is the first time a man has stepped foot inside this place since its founding!"

"I heard that not even Leader Bai's father could enter this place. Who is this man that she finds more important than her own father?"

"I couldn't get a look at his face because he was wearing a mask, but I swear I heard Leader Bai addressing him as 'Yuan!'"

"What?! It must be Player Yuan! I heard that she had an encounter with him in Cultivation Online. They probably agreed to meet in real life!"

"Oh my! This is so exciting!"

Meanwhile, in one of the guest rooms, Fiery Queen overheard some of the disciples in the hallway talking about Yuan.

"What? Player Yuan is here? That crafty bitch! No wonder why she's been gone for the last few days! She actually snuck out to meet him! And she even lied to me about it!"

She left her room shortly after to look for White Lotus and Yuan.

Sometime later, Fiery Lotus found them resting under a pavilion.

"What do you think of my faction?" White Lotus asked him as they sipped on hot tea.

"It's very peaceful here, and the disciples are full of enthusiasm. Honestly, I feel a little embarrassed to even call my place a faction after seeing how organized this place is. It's more like a home than a headquarter."

"I think most factions are like that. Only those with enough funds and reputation dare to build such a large headquarter." White Lotus said.

Suddenly—

"E-Excuse me! You can't go in there!" Someone there said in a nervous voice.

White Lotus turned around to see Fiery Queen approaching them with a nonchalant expression on her face.

"Yuan, that's Sasha Walkers, also known as Fiery Queen. She's a top 10 Player in Cultivation Online, and she's from the Walkers Family that is ranked 10th in the Legacy Ranking." White Lotus quickly introduced her to Yuan.

Once she arrived before their table, Fiery Queen combed her short orange hair with her fingers and spoke, "Are you really Player Yuan?"

Feeling her sharp gaze, Yuan smiled and nodded, "How can I help you, Miss Walkers?"

"Oh? You know about me?"

"I only know of your name."

"I see... Well, I don't like beating around the bush, so I am going to ask you directly. Join my Walkers Family, Player Yuan!"

"What can you offer me?" Yuan didn't immediately reject her offer.

'Is this what he meant by entertaining them?' White Lotus wondered inwardly.

"I will double— No, triple what the Bai Family has offered you!"

"Are you sure you can afford it?" White Lotus could no longer remain quiet now that Fiery Queen brought her family into the conversation.

"Your Bai Family may be higher in the Legacy Rankings, but my Walkers Family is ranked second in terms of wealth."

"Tell me, what did your Bai Family offer him to join your family?" Fiery Queen asked.

White Lotus smiled and said, "Actually, we didn't offer him anything."

"What?" Fiery Queen's eyes widened with disbelief.

"Y-You think I would fall for such a cheap trick? Why would he come here if you didn't pay him?"

"It's true." Yuan said.

And he continued, "Neither the Bai Family nor White Lotus has asked me to join their family. I am here on my own accord. In fact, I was the one who requested to be here."

"N-No way... Why would you do such a thing? Aren't you aware that every Legacy Family is trying to acquire you? If you do something like this, it's only natural for people to think that the Bai Family had bought you."

"I have my own reasons for being here." Yuan calmly said.

Fiery Queen gritted her teeth in frustration.

'Is he here because of White Lotus? Did he get charmed by her? This is bad... At this rate, the Bai Family will acquire him! What can I do in this situation?'

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Chapter 980 - Fiery Queen's Offer

Chapter 980 - Fiery Queen's Offer

"Si-Since the Bai Family hasn't offered you anything, then allow me to offer you to join the Walkers Family. What do you want? As long as it's something that money can buy, we will give it to you." Fiery Queen said to him after pondering for a moment.

"Sorry, but there's nothing I want." Yuan calmly responded.

"What? That's not possible. Everyone has something they desire."

"Indeed, that is true. However, what I want cannot be purchased with money."

"You won't know until you try. Love, happiness, fame— anything can be bought. Tell me what you desire and the Walkers Family will do everything in its power to acquire."

After a moment of silence, Yuan spoke in a calm voice, "If I say that I want the Walkers Family, will you be able to hand it over to me?"

"T-That's—!" Fiery Queen was dumbfounded by Yuan's question.

"What's wrong? Why are you hesitating? Didn't you say that you would give me anything? Or are you going to ask me to not be so greedy?"

"I'm sorry, but I don't think we can fulfill such an unreasonable condition. Anything else but that, please."

Yuan shook his head, "Sorry, but I was only joking. I don't plan on joining any Legacy Family, so you can stop asking."

"Can I ask why? You would gain a lot of benefit if you joined us. Or do you plan on creating your own family?" Fiery Queen narrowed her eyes at Yuan.

"I have no interest in the Legacy Ranking. As for why I don't want to join any Legacy Families... I don't want to break the current balance." He said.

"I don't want to sound arrogant, but if I join any family, even the lowest ranking family, it would immediately break the balance, and I'm sure nobody wants that to happen."

'Breaking the balance...?'

Both Fiery Queen and White Lotus frowned upon hearing this, as neither of them had thought about it like this until he mentioned it.

'He's right... If someone like him joins the Legacy Ranking, the family he chooses will immediately become the most powerful and influential family in the Legacy Ranking regardless of their previous rank.' White Lotus thought to herself.

'The other Legacy Families will probably work with each other to destroy such an unbalanced family. In other words, the moment he joins a Legacy Family, there will be a war...' Fiery Queen sighed.'

As much as she wanted to acquire Yuan for her family, she did not want to fight with the other Legacy Families simply because they had him.

After pondering for a few moments, Fiery Queen smiled and said, "Very well, I will give up on trying to recruit you. However, I have another proposal."

"While it's true that the other Legacy Families won't be happy if we pay to acquire you, they won't have anything to say if you marry into our family!"

She pointed at herself and said, "If you marry me, that will solve everything!"

"What nonsense are you saying?!" White Lotus slammed the table, startling everyone there.

"Nonsense? I think it's quite ingenious!" Fiery Queen said in a prideful tone.

"Yuan, forget about her. She's a lost cause."

"W-Wait! I was only joking!" Fiery Queen suddenly said.

And she continued, "Here's my real proposal. Instead of asking you to join our family, I will pay for your assistance."

"Can you elaborate?" Yuan asked.

"Basically, I want to hire you."

"And what kind of job do you want me to do?"

"I'm not sure yet, but we'll probably ask for you to do something for us in Cultivation Online. Maybe even train some of our players."

"If that's too much to ask, then I buy information from you instead—information about Cultivation Online."

Yuan pondered about Fiery Queen's offer.

'Although I can acquire money by selling Cultivation Online treasures like last time, I will be going to the Third Heaven soon, and that will make it difficult for me to use their auction house, especially since I will be busy traveling the world.'

'However, if I can sell information about Cultivation Online, I can earn money just by telling them about my experience in Cultivation Online, which is essentially free money.'

"How much are we talking about?" Yuan then asked.

"That will depend on the information you give us. We will give you a fixed price for each information you give us, and then we will pay you a bonus depending on its usefulness. How does that sound?"

"In other words, if my information helps you acquire treasures or other valuables, you will pay me extra?"

"Exactly." Fiery Queen nodded.

"Sure, I don't mind if it's just selling information." Yuan agreed.

'Yes!' Fiery Queen celebrated inwardly.

"Leave your contact information with me and I will contact you later." Yuan then said.

"Of course!"

Fiery Queen immediately handed Yuan her business card.

"Then I await your call! Thank you!" Fiery Queen left the place shortly after.

As much as she wanted to linger and talk more with Yuan, she didn't want to push her luck.

"If you don't mind me asking, why did you agree to working with her?" White Lotus asked him afterward.

"It seemed like an easy way to earn money, so why not? If things don't work out, I can stop working with her whenever I want." Yuan said.

"A-Are you, by some chance, having money problems?" She couldn't help but ask him.

Yuan chuckled, "It's embarrassing to admit it, but yes, I'm actually quite broke right now. I plan on selling some treasures that I'd found in Cultivation Online in the future, though."

A flicker appeared in White Lotus' eyes after hearing his words, and she quickly said, "I-If you don't mind, can you sell these treasures to my Bai Family?!"

"Are you sure? You don't even know what kind of treasures they are."

"We can figure these things out later!"

"Sure. Once I return home, we can meet in Cultivation Online. I will show you the treasures then." Yuan nodded.

"Thank you!" White Lotus said excitedly.

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Chapter 981 - Staying Overnight

Chapter 981 - Staying Overnight

After their break ended, Yu Rou asked, "Brother, would you like to see my room?"

"Sure."

Sometime later, they entered Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi's room.

"What do you think?" She asked him.

"It's exactly as I expected it to be— neat and clean." Yuan smiled.

Once they looked around the room, Yu Rou suddenly asked, "Will you be staying with us tonight?"

"I don't want to bother White Lotus and this place any longer, so I will return to the hotel." Yuan shook his head.

"A-Actually, it's fine if you want to stay here overnight. We have plenty of guest rooms, and it would be more convenient if you intend to spend more time with each other tomorrow." White Lotus said.

"Are you sure? I don't want to intrude any more than necessary."

"It's fine, really."

"Then I'll accept your offer."

"Great. I'll have your rooms prepared right away."

White Lotus left the room shortly after.

"By the way, I have something really important to tell you later." Yuan said to Yu Rou a moment later.

"I don't like the sound of that. Is it bad news or good news?" Yu Rou frowned slightly.

"Well... It's not really bad news, but it's not good news either. It's about Cultivation Online and how it affects our lives."

"I don't get it."

"I'll explain it once White Lotus returns."

"All right."

White Lotus returned to the room about five minutes later.

"I have arranged your rooms for tonight," she said to them.

"Thank you. Anyways, now that you're here, let's continue our conversation. I wanted to tell you guys at the pavilion just now, but Fiery Queen interrupted and I'd rather keep this between us."

Yuan removed his mask and looked at White Lotus with a serious gaze, "What I am about to tell you is highly confidential, so please keep it a secret even from your family. If it's leaked to the public, there will be an outcry, and who knows how the people will react to it."

"My lips are sealed no matter what you say from this point forth." White Lotus nodded.

"Good, now listen carefully."

After taking a deep breath, Yuan proceeded to tell them the truth about Cultivation Online and the connections it has with their own world.

Although Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi already knew that treasures inside Cultivation Online affected their real bodies, this was news to White Lotus, who was shocked speechless even before the grand reveal.

"The world of Cultivation Online, also known as Nine Heavens, truly exists in this universe somewhere, and our world, Earth, used to be part of the Nine Heavens before it was split."

"Wa-Wait..." White Lotus had to stop him, as she was unable to comprehend all of it at once.

"The Nine Heavens is a real world? How does that work?"

"The consoles that we use to enter Cultivation Online actually transfers a part of our soul to the Nine Heaven, and using another method, it creates our character with our soul."

"The reason we don't die when we 'die' inside Cultivation Online is simply because we didn't experience true death. When we die, our character will transform back into its soul form."

"This is also why some people lose their ability to cultivate after dying. Their soul had probably sustained too much damage, crippling them for real."

"Furthermore, this is why we are stuck with one character no matter whose console we use to play Cultivation Online."

Yu Rou and the other two stared at Yuan with their eyes as wide as saucers.

"No way... Why would they do such a thing?" Yu Rou muttered in a dazed voice.

"I don't know, but I plan on finding out the truth." Yuan said.

"However, now that you know your character is actually your soul, please do your best to avoid getting damaged, as it could damage your soul. Your soul is basically your spirit— your very existence. If it's damaged, you'll

turn into what they call a 'vegetable'. And if your soul is destroyed, you basically die without any chance of reincarnation..."

"If this is true, shouldn't we warn the public so that they could stop acting so recklessly in Cultivation Online?" White Lotus asked.

"Yes, but there's a good chance that a lot of people will stop playing Cultivation Online. I don't know what the Celestial Emperor has planned, but it clearly needs a lot of people. If a large number of people suddenly stop playing, who knows what the Celestial Emperor might do next." Yuan said.

And he continued, "A good portion of our soul is already trapped inside in the Nine Heavens. We're all basically held hostage by the Celestial Emperor until we can go to the Nine Heavens with our real body."

"But how are we going to travel to a place that we can't even locate?" Yu Rou asked.

"I already have a clue. I just need some time to figure it out."

"If you really want to warn people about the dangers of being hurt in Cultivation Online, then you must do so without revealing the truth to them." Yuan said to White Lotus a moment later.

"I understand. I will do my best. I don't want my family or the disciples of my faction to suffer because of this. Thank you for telling me the truth, Yuan. I will be seeing Cultivation Online in a new light now."

Later that night, White Lotus approached Yuan and said to him, "I have spoken to my father about buying your treasures in Cultivation Online, and he has agreed to it. If you're not busy, we can do it now. But if you insist on doing this later, I can wait."

"Let's do it now." Yuan nodded, and he continued, "I will meet you at the same place as last time in a few hours."

"Great! We have plenty of unused consoles. You can use one of those!"

"Then I will see you later."

Once he had a console, Yuan laid on his bed and entered Cultivation Online.

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Chapter 982 - A Pile of Treasures

Chapter 982 - A Pile of Treasures

"Welcome back, Brother Yuan." Xiao Hua greeted him when he entered Cultivation Online.

"Are we ascending the Stairway to Heaven soon?" Feng Yuxiang asked.

"No, not yet. I am only back temporarily to sell some treasures." Yuan shook his head.

"With that being said, it should be long before I challenge the Stairway to Heaven. I still have some business that requires my attention."

Sometime later, Yuan arrived at the restaurant with the musicians, where he'd first meet with White Lotus.

"Yuan!" White Lotus waved at him from her table.

Of course, she was surrounded by young men that were trying to hit on her again.

When these young men saw Yuan, they sneered in disdain. However, when Yuan released some of his aura, these young men started running for their lives.

"This isn't an appropriate place to show my treasures, but I still want to enjoy this place for a bit before we start our business." Yuan said to her.

"No problem. I was also thinking that we could enjoy the music for a while before our business."

After ordering some food and tea, the two of them quietly enjoyed the performance at the center of the restaurant.

About an hour later, White Lotus asked him, "Where should we go to do our business?"

"We can just rent a hotel somewhere and do it there," he calmly said.

"That sounds good."

Once they finished their meal and were satisfied with the entertainment, the two of them rented a room at a nearby hotel.

"All right, here are all of the treasures that I am trying to sell." Yuan proceeded to dump all of the treasures he had acquired from the Gu Family and the Blood Sect.

White Lotus stared at the large pile of treasures on the bed with wide eyes.

There were so many treasures that the table wouldn't fit them, hence the bed.

"Th-This is a lot more than what I had in mind..." She muttered in a dazed voice.

The amount of treasures before her eyes at this moment is more than what her family and faction has collected since the beginning of the game... combined.

'How on earth did he acquire so much treasure? It's almost as though he'd robbed an entire sect...' White Lotus was in disbelief.

"Take your time." Yuan said to her as he took a seat at the table and started studying array symbols.

"What are you doing?" She couldn't help but ask.

"I'm studying array symbols. They're more important and widely used than I realized."

After a moment of silence, she spoke again, "Yuan, this amount of treasure is too much to look through by myself. If you don't mind, can I have some assistance? My most trusted bodyguard, Jasmine, and my father, happen to be in this city as well."

Of course, it wasn't a coincidence. She had them prepared just in case anything were to happen.

"Sure, I don't mind." Yuan casually said.

"Thank you! I will contact them right away!"

White Lotus logged off for a couple of minutes before returning.

Sometime later, Jasmine and Bai Mengyao showed up at the hotel.

"It's a pleasure to see you again, Yuan." Bai Mengyao greeted him with a bright smile.

"Hello, Mister Bai. Sorry to bother you this late."

"It's not a bother at all." He laughed.

"Then the treasures are on the bed. Take your time."

"T-This is..." Jasmine and Bai Mengyao were stunned by the amount of treasures there even though White Lotus had already warned them about it through the phone.

'I thought she was exaggerating when she called it a 'pile' of treasures...' Bai Mengyao cried inwardly.

"Let's get to work, shall we?" White Lotus said to them.

Thus, the three of them started looking through the treasures one by one while Yuan focused on his array symbols.

Although Yuan didn't pay any attention to White Lotus and her group because he trusted them, the beings within his body kept a close eye on

their every movement just in case they had any funny ideas.

About an hour later, Bai Mengyao wiped the sweat from his forehead and sighed in a nervous voice, "Most of these treasures are Earth-grade and Heaven-grade. If I have to be honest, this will bankrupt us if we try to buy all of them."

"I know..." White Lotus sighed.

The two of them had planned on buying all of Yuan's treasure before, but after seeing just how many treasures were available, they immediately gave up such a thought.

"Although I already know what I want, I am going to look through them again just in case." White Lotus said a moment later.

"Me too."

Thus, they started examining the treasures again.

An hour later, White Lotus returned to Yuan and said to him, "We're ready."

Yuan nodded and stopped studying array symbols.

"We'd like to purchase these treasures." Bai Mengyao placed all of the treasures they wanted to buy on the table before him.

There were a total of 52 treasures, and most of them were Earth-grade with a couple of Heaven-grade treasures.

"Sure." Yuan nodded without even checking the treasures.

"For the pricing, in order to make this as far as possible, we will use the COPlayerAuctions for reference. If you have any objections, please let us know."

"I don't mind." Yuan said.

"Great. Most Earth-grade treasures sell for 10 million to 100 million dollars nowadays, and Heaven-grade treasures cost anywhere between 200 million dollars and 400 million dollars depending on its grade and usefulness."

"We have 42 Earth-grade and 10 Heaven-grade treasures. We will let you decide the price for each of them."

Yuan glanced at the treasures and said, "How about 2 billion for all of them?"

"Huh?"

They looked at him with wide eyes.

"Is that too expensive? I don't mind lowering—"

"N-No. That's not it. It's actually cheaper than we thought." Bai Mengyao quickly interrupted.

"It's a discount. Consider it as my gratitude for the past few days. If you want, you can go pick out some more treasures." Yuan said to them.

"Are you sure? We don't want to take advantage of you..." White Lotus was hesitant.

"It's fine." Yuan nodded with a smile.

After all, these treasures were all useless to him, and he wanted them to feel indebted to him just in case he needed their help in the future.

Chapter 983 - Sparring With White Lotus

Chapter 983 - Sparring With White Lotus

Once they received Yuan's approval to buy more treasure from him at a discount, the Bai Family returned to the bed and started picking out even more treasures to purchase.

In the end, they decided to just buy all of his treasures.

"How much do you want for all of these treasures?" Bai Mengyao asked him.

Yuan looked at the treasures and pondered. There were 201 treasures in total.

"How does 10 billion sound? You can easily get 10 billion back and then some more if you decide to sell them afterward."

Bai Mengyao pondered for a moment before nodding, "Deal! I'll buy all of your treasures for 10 billion!"

"Great. It's a pleasure doing business with you." Yuan shook his hand.

"You can give my daughter your bank information later. We'll send you the money as soon as possible. It'll take three days minimum, but we should have it sent over by tomorrow." Bai Mengyao said.

"Take your time." Yuan nodded.

"As for the treasures, you can take them now."

"Are you sure? We can wait until the payment is through." White Lotus said.

"It's fine. I want to get rid of them as soon as possible, anyway. They're taking up too much space."

Bai Mengyao swallowed nervously after seeing how casual Yuan was being with these treasures, almost as though he was just getting rid of trash in a garage sale.

Although Earth-grade and Heaven-grade treasures are incredibly valuable to other players, they could be considered trash in Yuan's eyes. In fact, he still has several Divine-grade treasures that he plans on selling in the auction house, where he will definitely fetch more money than selling it to the Bai Family.

"Once again, thank you for selling these treasures to us. I will make sure they're all put to good use." White Lotus bowed to him in a respectful manner.

Yuan logged off the game and called Wang Ming shortly after.

"Hey, get on Cultivation Online and meet me at the city square. I have some things for you." Yuan said to him.

"Sure thing."

Sometime later, Yuan met up with Wang Ming at the city square.

"Hey, how did your sister's birthday go? And when do you plan on coming back? The mansion feels empty without your presence." Wang Ming asked him.

"The birthday went pretty well, but it wasn't entirely smooth sailing. Don't worry, it's already been taken care of. As for when we'll return... I'm not sure, but it shouldn't take more than a week."

"I understand. I won't ask for any details now, but make sure to tell us about it when you get back. Anyways, what do you have for me?"

Yuan handed him a spatial ring and said, "I want you to sell these treasures in COPlayerAuctions."

"You mean that online auction house that all of the big families use? I heard their popularity skyrocketed after you sold an item there." Wang Ming recalled.

"Yes, and make sure to tell them that these treasures are from me. They'll treat you better that way."

"I'm a little scared to look at the inside... Oh, do you want me to sell them one by one or all at once?" Wang Ming then asked.

"You'll get more if you sell them one by one. They're all Divine-grade treasures, after all."

"D-Divine?!" Wang Ming exclaimed in a shocked voice before covering his own mouth.

"The last time a Divine-grade item was sold on that platform was when you sold that zither..."

"And that was only a low-quality treasure. All of these are high-quality treasures, so they should be able to fetch a billion with ease." Yuan smiled.

"I see... When do you want me to sell them?" Wang Ming proceeded to ask.

"Whenever you want. I just earned 10 billion selling the other treasures, so I am not in a rush to earn more money right now."

"Ten billion? What the hell did you sell to earn that much money?"

"Forget it, I don't even want to know." Wang Ming shook his head.

"Anything else you want me to do?" He then asked.

"Give the others one ring." Yuan proceeded to hand him 6 spatial rings.

"Are these..."

"Yes, they're resources that will support you while I am gone."

"Once again, I am a little scared to see the inside..." Wang Ming sighed.

"Hmm? Wait. Why are there 9 rings? Since Li Jinxi will be following you, we only have 6 people."

"One of them is for my friend who will be joining us soon. The other two rings are for my sister and her friend. Give it to them when you have the chance."

"I understand."

Yuan logged off Cultivation Online shortly after and went to rest.

The following day, Yuan proceeded to spend the entire day watching Yu Rou live her life as a disciple of the faction.

During his second day at the faction, Yu Rou decided to challenge Yuan.

"Please spar with me!" Yu Rou said to him with a serious look on her face.

"Sure." Yuan nodded without hesitation.

"And don't you dare go easy on me!"

"I won't." Yuan smiled behind his mask.

With nothing but a wooden sword in his grasp, Yuan proceeded to smack Yu Rou around until she could no longer stand back up.

The fight was so one-sided that it looked almost comical.

"I-I know I said to not go easy on me, but did you have to be so brutal? Ahh... I can't feel anything but pain right now..." Yu Rou complained after the spar ended a few minutes later.

"This is how I normally train with the people in my faction. And I didn't hit you that hard. You're exaggerating."

"Exaggerating?! Look at my hand! It's already bruised!"

Yuan laughed, "It'll heal in a few hours."

"Now that I think about it... This is the first time that you've hit me." Yu Rou said a moment later.

"Huh? This doesn't count. It's a spar."

"Whatever. I'm too exhausted to deal with you now."

Suddenly, one of the disciples there approached Yuan and bowed to him, "E-Excuse me! Senior Yuan! Can I also request a spar with you?!"

Yuan looked at this cute and delicate girl and nodded, "Sure."

Sometime later, shortly after his second spar ended, a third followed, and this would continue until Yuan had sparred with everyone there.

"Thank you for the spar, Senior Yuan..." The last disciple to spar with him said as she laid on the floor.

"Thank you for sparring with me." Yuan nodded.

"After seeing you spar with so many people, I am starting to feel like sparring with you too, even though I know that I will lose." White Lotus said with a bittersweet smile on her face.

"If you want to spar as well, I won't mind." Yuan offered his wooden sword to her.

White Lotus looked at the sword with a nervous look on her face.

'If I lose to him before so many disciples, I will definitely lose some face, but if I don't fight him, they others will think that I am a coward. Either way, it's my loss...' White Lotus sighed inwardly.

In the end, White Lotus accepted the sword and agreed to spar with Yuan.

'Even if I lose to him and lose some face, it's a lot better than being labeled a coward!' She thought to herself.

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Chapter 984 - Leaving Eternal Lotuses

Chapter 984 - Leaving Eternal Lotuses

"Good luck, Senior Bai! Good luck, Senior Yuan!"

The disciples cheered for them as they entered the sparring area.

"Ready whenever you are." Yuan said to White Lotus, who stood a couple meters away with a serious expression on her face.

"Here I come!" White Lotus announced right before she approached him with a wooden sword.

Yuan calmly and casually dodged the attack, but White Lotus immediately followed up with a second strike.

Thud!

Yuan effortlessly blocked it with his wooden sword.

"Not bad." He swung the sword, forcing White Lotus to retrieve several steps.

'What tyrannical strength! It only looked like he had casually moved his sword, yet it felt as though I had been struck by a large hammer!' White Lotus was shocked after experiencing Yuan's strength for the first time.

Although she was aware of his prowess, it was a whole different story to experience it first-hand.

"Are you okay?" Yuan asked her when she stopped moving.

"Sorry, I lost focus for a second. It won't happen again." White Lotus tightened her grip on the sword and proceeded to attack Yuan again.

The disciples that had been cheering at the beginning quickly stopped when they realized how one-sided the fight between Yuan and White Lotus was.

"I thought Senior Bai would be able to pressure him even if it's just a little, but looking at them now, their fight doesn't seem anything different from the previous spars! He's treating her like a child just like he did to the rest of us!" The disciples were shocked when they realized this.

"Senior Yuan is much more profound and powerful than I anticipated... I wonder what cultivation level he has achieved."

"Seeing how he's handling Senior Bai with so little effort, he's definitely already a Spirit Master."

'More like a Spirit Grandmaster.' Yu Rou and Xia Jingyi thought to themselves after hearing their topic.

Fifteen minutes later, White Lotus collapsed on the ground and said in an exhausted manner, "I-I surrender."

"Thank you for the spar." Yuan said to her before reaching his hand out to her.

White Lotus grabbed it with a defeated smile on her face.

The disciples started cheering once again even though their faction leader had lost, as it was an entertaining spar, and they learned a lot as spectators.

"How much will it cost to hire you to train us?" White Lotus asked him in a somewhat joking tone after getting back to her feet.

"If you come to the Dragon Spiral Mountain, I can train you guys for free."

"Seriously?" White Lotus did not expect such an answer and was taken aback by it.

"Yes. We have plenty of room there, and it seems fun, like a collaboration of sorts between the factions." He nodded.

"Then I will seriously consider your offer."

Sometime later, Fiery Queen showed up, "What are you guys doing? It looks fun."

"You're still here? Why don't you leave already? You have already achieved what you came here for, anyway." White Lotus said to her.

"I will leave when Yuan leaves." Fiery Queen said in a shameless manner.

"Don't worry, I won't stay here for long." Yuan said.

"By the way, I have spoken to my family about our business. They have agreed to it, so you can sell us information whenever you want."

"I'll contact you in a week or so."

"I'll be waiting."

At the end of the day, Yuan said to Yu Rou, "I have decided to leave after tomorrow."

"You're leaving already?"

He nodded, "If I make the Yu Family wait too long, who knows what they'll do."

"Actually, they have been trying to contact me since your concert. I ignored all of them, though. They can't do anything to me as long as I am a member of this faction, anyway. This is even more true now that White Lotus is aware of your real identity." Yu Rou chuckled.

Yuan notified White Lotus about his leave the following morning.

"I see... So you're leaving already. It hasn't been that long since we met, but it feels like I have known you for years now." White Lotus said to him.

"Feel free to visit me whenever you want." Yuan smiled.

"And you're free to visit us whenever you want. Our faction will always have its doors open for you."

"That's good to hear."

After spending the entire day with Yu Rou, Yuan also spent the last night sleeping with her.

"Don't do anything crazy when you get back, Brother." Yu Rou said to them as they prepared to go to sleep.

"I will try not to, but it's going to be hard."

"As long as you don't do anything that will make you a criminal, I will be fine with it."

Yuan silently nodded with a smile.

The two of them fell asleep shortly after.

The following morning, a good portion of the people at Eternal Lotuses gathered at the entrance to see Yuan and his group off.

Yu Rou, Xia Jingyi, and White Lotus followed them all the way to the airport.

"When do you think I will see you guys again?" Yu Rou asked them.

"I will try to visit you once a month." Yuan said.

"That would be great, but since I know that you're a busy man, let's not make any schedules and just see each other whenever we can. I will also try to visit you once in a while." Yu Rou said.

"Sure."

"Also, your birthday is coming up in three months, right? I will be the one to visit you then, so make sure you're free on that day."

"It's a promise." Yuan nodded.

He then turned to look at White Lotus and said to her, "See you later. Despite the slight inconvenience we had, I had fun the last few days."

"Me too. We should play together in Cultivation Online sometimes."

"Of course."

After saying their final goodbyes, the two groups hugged each other.

Yuan's group boarded the plane shortly after while Yu Rou and White Lotus returned to the faction.

Chapter 985 - Returning to the Yu Family

Chapter 985 - Returning to the Yu Family

After boarding the plane, Chu Liuxiang asked Yuan, "So, what do you think of this trip?"

"Exhausting..." He sighed.

"Yu Rou... She knows about our relationship."

"Eh?" Chu Liuxiang's eyes widened with surprise.

"Really?"

"Yes, she asked me about it during the night of her birthday, and I had no choice but to tell her the truth."

"I see... How did she take it?"

"I honestly don't know. She seems okay with it, but she doesn't seem happy about it either." Yuan shook his head.

"That's tough... However, I kind of understand her feelings... I think." Chu Liuxiang sighed, and she turned to look at Meixiu and asked, "What do you think?"

"I also don't know... All I can say is that it's really complicated..." Meixiu also shook her head.

Chu Liuxiang raised her eyebrows since Meixiu's words contradicted herself. If she doesn't know anything, why would she say it's complicated like she knew about it?

However, Chu Liuxiang decided to not ask her about it.

"Anyways, I'm surprised the Bai Family allowed you to leave so easily. In fact, I was so sure that they'd try to recruit you."

Yuan smiled and said, "Well, I'm really glad that they didn't. It wouldn't be easy to refuse them after all they've done for me and Yu Rou."

The three of them proceeded to talk about their short and chaotic vacation for most of their flight.

Meanwhile, White Lotus notified her father about Yuan's departure.

"I see... So he's gone... What about your relationship with him?" Bai Mengyao asked.

"Honestly, while I will admit that I was too nervous to approach him, I also think it's a little too early for me to propose to him. Although I wasn't able to join his family, I think I've made great progress in our relationship. Once I am ready, I will ask him." White Lotus said.

"Nervous? You? Hahaha!" Bai Mengyao laughed out loud.

"I never thought I'd ever hear such words coming from you!"

"Shut up... I'm going to hang up now. I have some things that I want to discuss with Yu Rou."

"All right. Let me know if you need anything."

"I will."

A few hours later, Yuan's plane landed.

"Can you call your mother and let her know that we will be arriving at the Yu Family soon?" Yuan asked Meixiu.

She nodded and proceeded to call Meifeng on her phone.

"Hello? Yes, we have just landed. We should arrive at the Yu Family soon."

"No, we can get there by ourselves."

"I understand. I will let him know."

After hanging up, Meixiu looked at Yuan and spoke, "Apparently your parents are furious that you kept them waiting for so long."

Yuan smiled and said, "I know they're legally my parents, but let's not call them that for my sanity's sake."

"By the way, Lulu, since the Yu Family is only expecting Meixiu and I, and I don't want to make things more complicated than it already is, can you wait for us to be done? They're pretty awful people, so I doubt you would want to meet with them either."

Chu Liuxiang chuckled, "Too bad I have already met with your parents. However, I was still from the Chu Family at that time, so they had to be respectful to me. Don't worry, I won't interrupt your family reunion. Go on and have fun without me."

"Thank you."

They took a taxi to the Yu Family shortly after.

"It's been a while since I have been to this city so I am going to stroll around for a bit. Call me when you're done." Chu Liuxiang said to them before going elsewhere.

Once Chu Liuxiang was gone, Yuan and Meixiu approached the Yu Family's manor.

"How long has it been since I last seen this place? Feels like forever." Yuan looked at the scenery with a nostalgic expression on his face.

Even though his childhood was horrible, he still had some fond memories of this place.

When they arrived at the front gate, Yuan could see a familiar figure standing inside.

"It's been a while, Miss Meifeng." Yuan greeted her with a smile.

"Mother." Meixiu nodded at her.

"Young Master... Your eyes... So it's true that you've fully recovered..." Meifeng covered her mouth after seeing that Yuan's eyes had regained its beautiful color.

Even though she had seen the concert, she still doubted it.

"Where's the couple?" Yuan then asked her.

"They're currently inside, and it's not just them. Their lawyers and even some of the investors are inside, waiting for your arrival." Meifeng said with a worried frown on her face.

"Wow, what a grand audience that they have prepared for us. I kind of feel bad for making them wait so long now." Yuan chuckled.

"Young Master, I have to be honest with you. You should've just remained in hiding. Why did you show yourself so soon?" Meifeng asked him.

"I just figured that it's about time I stop hiding and confront my problems." Yuan casually shrugged.

"Don't worry, I am no longer the pushover they once knew. Let us in, Miss Meifeng. I will handle the Yu Family." Yuan said to her with a confident smile on his face.

Meifeng took a deep breath and released it a moment later.

"All right." She opened the gates from them and led them inside the Yu Family's territory.

Once inside, Meifeng drove the two of them to the manor that was located about half a mile away.

A few minutes later, when they exited the car, Yuan and Meixiu could suddenly feel many gazes staring at them.

Yuan could see many people watching them from inside the manor. Most of them were servants working there, but a few of them were wearing suits.

After entering the manor, Meifeng led them to the audience room that is usually used for important business meetings.

Upon opening the door, Yuan could see Yu Yong and Tang Lee sitting at the end of a large table, and sitting beside them were a bunch of important-looking people that Yuan vaguely recognized.

Yuan stepped inside the room without any hesitation and with a smile on his handsome face.

"I'm home," he spoke in a calm voice.

Chapter 986 - Confronting the Yu Family

Chapter 986 - Confronting the Yu Family.

"Stay here with me." Meifeng said to Meixiu in a low voice when she tried to follow Yuan into the room.

She nodded and stood at the door with Meifeng.

BANG!

"Yu Tian!" Yu Yong slammed the desk with his fist and roared.

"How dare you make us wait this long for you! You should have come back the moment we called you!"

Yuan casually took a seat at the opposite end of the table where he could see everyone and said, "I thought you wanted me out of the family, so why do you suddenly want me back so badly? You were the one who abandoned me."

"So what if we kicked you out of the house? You're already an adult." Tang Lee sneered.

"An adult and a paralyzed cripple who couldn't move without the help of others, yet you still abandoned me."

"Enough. We didn't call you here just so you can bicker with your parents. Yu Tian, you have an obligation to continue working for the Yu Family's company." One of the people there suddenly said.

Yuan turned to look at him and asked with raised eyebrows, "Who are you?"

"I'm David Swanson, an investor and a manager at your father's company, and we're all here to make sure that you'll continue your obligation to your family."

"Father? He may have adopted me, but he's not my father. He's a disgrace to the real fathers out there that care for their own family."

"How dare you!" Yu Yong fumed after hearing Yuan's insults. In fact, this is his first time being ridiculed by Yuan.

"I don't care about your opinions. He is still legally your father, and your contract is still in effect."

"Contract? What contract? I don't remember signing anything." Yuan said in a surprised voice.

"This is the contract." The man immediately retrieved a piece of paper and showed it to Yuan, almost as though he had it prepared beforehand.

Yuan took a moment to read the contract that basically said that he was required to perform at least two concerts every week until he is 60 years old, and that all of the money he earns will be given to the Yu Family.

It was basically a slave contract that would work Yuan to the bones without giving him any in return.

Yuan laughed out loud after seeing his signature on the paper.

"Seriously? You went out of your way to forge this nonsense? Sorry, but I don't feel like working for the Yu Family, no matter what the contract says." Yuan casually ripped the contract to shreds and tossed it into the air.

The entire room turned silent after his little bold action.

"Did you think that you would be able to escape from us by ripping that piece of paper?" Tang Lee suddenly sneered in contempt.

"That was only a copy. However, even if you managed to destroy the original, we have plenty of ways to make you submit."

"Oh? What do you have in mind? Please share with us." Yuan smiled.

"For starters, we can make your life miserable. No matter what job you decide to take, we have the power to fire you on the same day that you joined."

"Without having any sources of income, you'll have to start begging in the streets sooner or later."

"If I can't find an ordinary job, I can simply sell my music talents to other companies. I'm sure that they will accept me even if you threaten them. After all, I am worth a lot of money." Yuan shrugged.

"Or I can just play Cultivation Online and earn money that way. The game is pretty popular, so I should be able to earn some decent money from it."

"That kind of threat is hardly a threat at all." He even chuckled.

Tang Lee narrowed her eyes at him and continued, "We can easily throw you into jail and let you live the rest of your pathetic life there."

"Prison, huh? That doesn't sound too bad, considering that I already have plenty of experience being a slave for the Yu Family."

Tang Lee gritted her teeth in frustration, feeling as though she was not dealing with the Yu Tian that she was so familiar with.

"What the hell happened to this bastard? It hasn't been that long since he started living without the support of our Yu Family. How can someone change so drastically in such a short time? He's no longer the coward and pushover that we once knew!"

Everyone in the room realized that they were no longer dealing with the same person that they used to take advantage of.

However, this didn't shake their resolve, and they continued to threaten Yuan.

When nothing was working, Yu Yong suddenly stood up and shouted, "That's it! I have had enough of this shit! Yu Tian! You will come back and start working for us again! If you don't, we will not punish you! Instead, we will make Yu Rou bear the responsibilities!"

Yuan frowned after hearing this, which caused the people in the room to smile, as they realized that they'd just found his weakness.

"You're going to punish your own blood because I refuse to work for you? What kind of parent are you?" Yuan spoke in a cold voice.

"You can only blame yourself for pushing us this far! If you work for us, nobody will get hurt!" Tang Lee said with a grin on her face.

"Yu Rou is currently a member of the faction 'Eternal Lotuses', right? If we pressure their leader, Bai Lianhua, who is still young and inexperienced, she will definitely be kicked out of the faction. Once that happens, we can do whatever we want to her and there's nothing you can do about it!"

The people there increased the pressure on Yuan.

'Yuan...' Meixiu stared at his face with a worried look on her face. However, she was not worried about Yuan. It was the others that she was worried about.

Yuan suddenly closed his eyes and took a deep breath.

'In the end, this is how things will go, huh?' He sighed inwardly.

When he opened his eyes again, they were completely golden, and the atmosphere in the room immediately changed.

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AN: Check out my other novel Magic System in a Parallel World while you wait for the next chapter. I will also be doing a rare gifting event where I

will mass release depending on the amount of gifts for either novels(I don't usually do mass releases). Surprise me and I will surprise you

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Chapter 987 - A Proposal

Chapter 987 - A Proposal

When Yuan activated Dragon's Gaze, the atmosphere in the room changed, and almost as though the temperature dropped to below freezing, the people in the room began trembling nonstop.

"Yo-You! Wha-What do you think you are doing?!" Yu Yong spoke in a trembling voice.

Even though Yuan used Dragon's Gaze, he didn't want these people to stop functioning, so he used the lowest output possible, but even then, most of these people could barely think under the pressure of the gaze.

"I will say this again... The two of you are a disgrace as parents. When you look at people, you don't see a human, you only see a tool— a tool that you can abuse for profit. People like you are better off dead." Yuan spoke in a calm voice.

"However, even if you are the scummiest people on earth, you are still Yu Rou's parents by blood. I would love to kill you, but I do not have the resolve to kill her parents."

"With that being said, that does not mean I am going to let you go without any punishment."

"Hahaha! Did you just say that you want to kill us?! You must be out of your damn mind! It appears that you have recovered your ability to move but lost your ability to think in the process! You will not get away with threatening us! We'll have you prosecuted!" Tang Lee pointed her fingers at him and roared.

But despite her brave words, her eyes were filled with fear, and her arm couldn't stop shaking.

"You're going to prosecute me for threatening you when you've done the same thing just moments ago? Are you listening to yourself, you damn crazy bitch?"

"W-What did you just call me?" Tang Lee's body shook violently after being cursed out by Yuan.

Meixiu and Meifeng stared at Yuan's nonchalant face with wide eyes and slightly opened mouths, seemingly in disbelief.

"Are you deaf as well? I called you a crazy bitch, since that's what you are." Yuan casually repeated.

"Guards! I want you to break his fingers!" Tang Lee shouted in a fury.

Two of the guards standing by the wall suddenly rushed at Yuan.

"Wai—!" Meifeng wanted to intervene, but Meixiu suddenly grabbed her hand.

"It's okay," she said in a calm voice.

Once the guards were close enough, they grabbed Yuan's arms and tried to restrict him.

However, they immediately realized that they were unable to move him.

"Get your hands off me." Yuan casually flicked his arms, sending the two guards flying.

The guards struck the wall with their bodies, creating a large crater in the wall before falling to the floor unconscious.

"That was self-defense." Yuan calmly said afterward without moving from his seat.

"Y-You..." The entire room fell silent after they witnessed what Yuan had just done.

'They were both Spirit Warriors! How did he beat them so easily?! What is his cultivation?!' Yu Yong cried inwardly.

"G-Guar—"

"Don't even bother trying to send more guards. You're just going to waste money on their treatment fees later— my money." Yuan interrupted Tang Lee.

"W-What are you talking about?" Tang Lee frowned.

"Let's get to the real reason why I came back today," he said with a smile.

"I'm here to get back everything that was taken from me, and that includes all of the money that I have earned throughout the years."

"Hahaha! You're truly out of your damn mind! As if we'd agree to your nonsense!" Tang Lee laughed out loud.

"I'm not asking. I'm demanding for my money back." Yuan increased the intensity of his Dragon's Gaze.

Tang Lee fell back to her chair the next moment from the intense pressure.

"Y-You're asking for the impossible, Yu Tian. Don't forget about your contract. The Yu Family doesn't owe you anything. In fact, you owe them money for being unable to work, which was part of you—"

Yuan looked at the person who just spoke and narrowed his eyes, "Can you shut up about the contract already? As if I give a damn about a piece of paper that you all forged. You can try to sue me if you want, but you might not be alive to do that."

"I might not be able to kill Yu Rou's parents, but you idiots are different. I can kill you right here and nobody will utter a single word about it."

"Hahaha! You have played too many video games! Do you really think you can get away with murder?! This is not Cultivation Online!" The man laughed out loud.

"Ahaha—Ahhhh!" The man suddenly stopped laughing and began screaming when he felt a sharp pain in one of his legs.

When he looked down, he could see the cause of the pain— a dagger stabbing into his thighs.

"W-What just happened?! Where did this weapon come from?!" The man was both terrified and confused.

"Mister Jiang, this is my first and last warning to you. If you don't want that dagger in your head, then you should keep your mouth shut. In fact, why don't you just abandon the Yu Family?"

Yuan suddenly thought of something and smiled.

"This may be sudden, but I have a proposal for everyone here. Stop supporting the Yu Family or die." Yuan swept the room with his gaze.

"What?!" They all exclaimed.

"After all, the real backbone of the Yu Family are the investors. Without you guys, they're basically powerless."

Everyone present in the room were the Yu Family's biggest investors and donors. Without them, the Yu Family will immediately lose over 90 percent of their power.

Furthermore, since he couldn't kill Yu Rou's parents, he had to punish them using other methods, and this is just one of many that he has in mind.

"You're fucking insane! As if we'd listen to you! You're just a damn child with a few loose screws!"

"I see... If threatening to kill you is not enough to convince you, then allow me to give you another reason to abandon the Yu Family." A mysterious

smile appeared on Yuan's face.

And he continued, "Player Yuan, I'm sure you've all heard of him."

"What if I tell you that I personally know him and that I can set up a meeting with him for all of you? Will you stop supporting the Yu Family then? I'm sure you'll be able to profit more from Player Yuan than from the Yu Family."

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Chapter 988 - Halting Their Support

Chapter 988 - Halting Their Support

"P-Player Yuan? Are you serious? You know Player Yuan?" The investors there were doubtful for obvious reasons.

"That's a load of bullshit! He doesn't know Player Yuan! He's just trying to mess with all of you!" Yu Yong slammed the table and shouted.

"T-That's right! There's no way a nobody like him could know Player Yuan when nobody even knows his true identity!" Tang Lee also spoke.

The investors looked at each other.

After a moment of silence, one of them said, "If you can prove to us that you know Player Yuan, I will stop supporting the Yu Family."

"Mister Joe! What are you saying?!" Yu Yong looked at him in shock.

"Proof, huh? Sure, I can prove it to you that I know Player Yuan." Yuan nodded, still with a smile on his face.

"However, before I give you proof, I'd like to talk about the other reason why I am here today."

After deactivating his Dragon's Gaze, Yuan turned to look at Meifeng and continued to speak, "Miss Meifeng, the Yu Family will go bankrupt soon, so why don't you come work for me instead?"

"Huh?" Meifeng's eyes widened with shock.

"Good luck with that! According to her contract, she will work for us for the rest of her life unless she pays the contract cancellation fee of 50 billion dollars! Even if we go bankrupt or become homeless, she will still have to work for us!" Tang Lee said with a wide smirk on her face.

"If I don't give a damn about my contract with the Yu Family, why would I care about hers?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"You can ignore your contract all you want, but that doesn't mean she will follow your recklessness. Isn't that right, Meifeng? If you ignore the contract and betray the Yu Family, not only will you get in trouble, but so will your family." Tang Lee looked at her with a threatening gaze.

Meifeng looked at Tang Lee and then at Meixiu.

"She's right, Young Master. I cannot ignore my contract. I have an obligation to fulfill my contract. Please don't make things difficult for me or my daughter..." Meifeng sighed.

"I see... That's unfortunate, but there's no need for you to feel bad about it." Yuan shook his head.

"If you cannot ignore your contract, then you can simply buy your way out of the contract."

"Y-Young Master... I don't have 50 billion dollars..."

"Maybe not right now, but you'll have it soon." Yuan smiled at her.

"And if I help you acquire enough money to buy out of your contract, would you do so?"

"I—"

"It's fine, I don't actually want you to answer that question." Yuan suddenly interrupted.

He returned his focus to the people at the table and continued, "Is there anyone here that can contact Chairman Lee from the Cultivators'?"

Association?"

"What does he have anything to do with this?" They asked.

"You wanted proof that I know Player Yuan, right? Call him and you will get it."

After a moment of silence, one of the people there said, "I will call Chairman Lee."

Once he dialed the numbers, everyone waited for Chairman Lee to answer the phone.

Several rings later, a voice resounded in the open speaker, "This is Chairman Lee from the Cultivators' Association speaking."

"Good morning, Chairman Lee. This is David Swanson. It's been a while since we last spoke. Do you remember me?"

"Of course I do, Mister Swanson. Your donations to the Cultivators' Association will never be forgotten. Anyways, how can I help you today?"

"You see, I have a friend here who would like to speak with you. Do you mind sparing us a few moments of your time?"

"Sure. I can spare some time."

David Swanson looked at Yuan and nodded.

"Hey, Chairman Lee, it's me." Yuan said out loud.

"H-Huh? This voice is..." Chairman Lee immediately recognized Yuan's voice, especially since he'd heard Yuan speak just a few days ago at the concert.

"What's going on? Did something happen between you and Mister Swanson?" Chairman Lee asked in a worried voice.

When the people there heard Chairman Lee's response, they all raised an eyebrow.

"Something like that." Yuan said.

And he continued, "I told him that I knew Player Yuan, but he doesn't believe me and even asked for proof. Can you, Chairman Lee of the Cultivators' Association, attest to my claims?"

"Of course!" Chairman Lee immediately responded.

"Mister Swanson! Can you hear me?!"

"I-I can..."

"Listen to me very carefully, Mister Swanson! I can confirm his claims! He really knows Player Yuan! In fact, they're practically best friends! Whatever you do, you better not upset my friend!" Chairman Lee said in a stern voice.

Everyone in the room was shocked by Chairman Lee's words.

After snapping out of his daze, David Swanson spoke, "W-Wait a second, Chairman Lee! It's not that I don't believe you, but do you even know who just spoke?! He didn't even introduce himself!"

"I can recognize him by his voice alone. We have spoken to each other many times, after all. He is Yu Tian, correct?"

"T-That is correct..." David Swanson muttered, not daring to believe his ears.

"Then I have nothing else to say to you. My friend Yu Tian, if you ever need anything, don't hesitate to call me, all right? I will talk to you later!" Chairman Lee hung up the next moment.

The entire room turned silent and nobody there would utter a single word for a whole minute.

"S-Since I have received Chairman Lee's words that you know Player Yuan, I would like to ask you again— Are you sure that you can help us meet Player Yuan?" David Swanson stared at Yuan with narrowed eyes.

"Of course. We can even meet him right after this if you want. He's currently in this city, after all." Yuan nodded.

"Seriously?! If you can really get us to meet with Player Yuan, I will stop our support for the Yu Family!" David Swanson said.

"M-Me too!" Another one exclaimed.

Soon, everyone in the room agreed to stop supporting the Yu Family, leaving Yu Yong and Tang Lee absolutely dazed.

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Chapter 989 - Taking Away Their Cultivation

Chapter 989 - Taking Away Their Cultivation

"W-What are you guys talking about? Please tell me that you're all joking!" Yu Yong spoke in a trembling voice after the investors for the Yu Family agreed to stop supporting them.

"Even if you meet Player Yuan, there's no guarantee that he will work with you! In fact, I am willing to bet all of my money that he won't!"

"That is a risk I am willing to take." David Swanson said in a calm manner.

Although he didn't mention it, he was actually afraid of offending Yu Tian any more due to his relationship with Yuan.

If they continue to offend Yu Tian, there is a good chance that they will offend Yuan as well, and based on the rumors around Yuan, he is not someone they want to offend even if they have to cut all ties with the Yu Family.

Furthermore, ever since Yu Tian stopped playing music for them, their profit had drastically decreased. The Yu Family in its current state wasn't worth investing in, and these investors were already thinking about severing ties with the Yu Family.

If Yu Rou's birthday was even a week later, these investors would have stopped their support for the Yu Family on their own accord.

"Now that you've lost all of your major supports, what are you going to do, 'Mother'? 'Father'?" Yuan looked at them with contempt, his gaze so cold

that it made the two feel as though they had been tossed into the abyss.

"Y-You won't get away with this! All of you will regret this!" Tang Lee spoke with gritted teeth.

"Let's go! We're leaving!" Yu Yong stood up.

"Where do you think you're going?" Yuan's eyes turned golden again.

And he continued in a cold voice, "You're done here when I say you're down. Now, sit back down."

An immense pressure suddenly fell on Yu Yong and Tang Lee, causing them to fall into their seats.

"Don't forget, you still owe me money. I will let you keep 50 billion since that's how much Miss Meifeng needs to buy out of her contract, but everything else is mine."

"Hahaha! As if we'd give you any money!" Tang Lee laughed in a crazed manner.

Yuan released a deep sigh.

"I didn't want to resort to this, but..."

He turned to look at Meixiu and spoke, "Can you make me some tea?"

The request was very sudden and unexpected, but Meixiu instantly understood what he was trying to do.

"Sure. Mother, can you help me? It's been a while, so I forgot how to make tea." Meixiu grabbed her hand and pulled her along to make tea.

"M-Meixiu?! What is going on?!" Meifeng asked her once they left.

"Who knows." She shrugged.

Meanwhile, inside the room, Yuan turned to look at the investors and said, "I no longer have any need for you all. Go to the Cultivators' Association and wait for me there. You'll meet Player Yuan by the end of the day."

The investors were still doubtful of him, but they had no choice. They were clearly up against a monster— one the Yu Family had created.

"Oh, right, before you all leave, I have one more question... What about the contract?"

"What contract are you talking about?" David Swanson asked with raised eyebrows.

"The one I signed with the Yu Family."

The investors looked at each other and laughed, "We don't know what you're talking about! Such a contract doesn't exist!"

Yuan smiled after hearing their words and nodded, "Then I'll see you all later."

Naturally, the contract existed, but the investors there knew what Yuan was trying to do, so they had no choice but to forget about the contract.

Once all of the people in the room except for Yu Yong and Tang Lee left, Yuan focused his attention on them.

"What do you think I should do with the two of you?" He asked as he slowly approached them.

Yu Yong and Tang Lee wanted to run, but they were unable to move their bodies, almost as though they were chained to the chair.

"So the both of you have managed to reach the first level Spirit Warrior. You must have worked hard to acquire such a profound cultivation. It would be a shame if you were to lose it all at once..." Yuan narrowed his eyes at them with a vicious gaze.

"Y-You wouldn't dare!" Yu Yong shouted.

"Do you really still think that I am the same person as before? If that's the case, allow me to open your eyes!"

"No! Stop! Help me! Somebody!" Yu Yong roared when he saw Yuan's motions.

Yuan ignored Yu Yong's cry for help and struck him in the chest with his palm.

"Gah!" Yu Yong coughed out a mouthful of blood, and he could feel his cultivation being destroyed.

"N-N-No! NO! NO! NO! NO! HOW DARE YOU! MY CULTIVATION!"

It took a moment for reality to sink in, but when it did, Yu Yong's face twisted in anger.

He'd spent many hours and tons of money to improve his cultivation, and for it to all disappear in an instant, it tortured his mind and heart.

"Soon, you will also know what it feels like to lose everything. I took your power first, then it will be your wealth, and lastly, I will take your entire family from you, just like what you did to me."

Yuan turned to look at the terrified Tang Lee next.

"Ple-Please! Wait! Spare me! I was wrong! Don't hurt me! I will do anything you want! I can destroy Meifeng's contract and hand her over to you! Please! I am still your mother!"

However, Yuan's face turned even colder after hearing her words.

"You dare call yourself my mother after everything you have done?!"

The pressure in the room increased.

"Don't you ever dare call yourself my mother again!" Yuan shouted as he thrust his palm into her chest, destroying her Dantian.

"NO!!!"

Tang Lee could feel all of the spiritual energy in her body dissipate in the following moments.

Yuan took a deep breath to calm himself down after destroying Yu Yong and Tang Lee's cultivation.

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Chapter 990 - I Am No Longer Yu Tian

Chapter 990 - I Am No Longer Yu Tian

Meixiu and Meifeng returned to the room with a cup of tea shortly after Yuan destroyed Yu Yong and Tang Lee's to see blood all over the couple's mouth and clothes.

"W-What in god's name happened here?! Young Master! What did you do?!" Meifeng was terrified when she saw the scene.

"Don't worry, I didn't kill them. I only destroyed their Dantian, taking away their cultivation forever." Yuan said in a calm voice.

Meifeng was speechless.

'What had happened to him since my visit a few months ago? He's changed into a completely different person! He's both ruthless and merciless!' Meifeng cried inwardly.

"Yu Tian... You will not get away with this..." Yu Yong muttered in a low voice despite the pain in his chest.

"Oh, I should have mentioned this earlier, but I am no longer Yu Tian," he said.

"Call me Yuan. That's my name now."

"What?!"

Both Yu Yong and Tang Lee turned to look at him with wide eyes filled with disbelief.

"Young Master... You don't mean..." Meifeng asked in a trembling voice.

"Yes, I am Player Yuan— I have been since the very beginning." He nodded, confirming their suspicions.

"No way..."

Both Yu Yong and Tang Lee began feeling emotions that they never experienced before after learning the truth behind Player Yuan.

Neither of them could have imagined that their own crippled son had been Player Yuan all along. It was a shocking revelation that drove them to the brink of insanity.

'We'd been chasing after our own son this entire time?'

As this reality sank into their minds, Yuan spoke, "I want all of my money — except the 50 billion— in this bank account by the end of the day."

"If I don't see the money by then, I will come back to completely cripple the two of you. And don't even try to stop me. There is nobody in this world that can stop me from taking back what is rightfully mine."

"Also, don't think I have forgotten about that time you hired people to kidnap Meixiu. One by one, I will slowly return the debt. The two of you have abused me for years. I won't let my revenge end so soon."

After placing his bank account information on the table before them, Yuan deactivated his Dragon's Gaze and started approaching Meifeng.

"Miss Meifeng, I have already paid them the 50 billion required for you to leave the Yu Family. I won't force you to work for me, nor will I tell you what to do from this point forth because you're free to do whatever you want from now." Yuan took the cup of tea from her hands and drank it in one motion.

"Perhaps you had a dream that you wanted to fulfill, or maybe you wanted to do another job. Whatever it is, I hope that you can find happiness in your new life. If you ever need any help, you can always contact me. I am currently living at the Dragon Spiral Mountain with Meixiu and my friends."

'T-The Dragon Spiral Mountain?! That's the most exclusive territory in this country! The Yu Family have been trying for years to move there!' Meifeng cried inwardly.

"Meixiu, let's go. I don't want to stay in this dump any longer."

"Okay." She nodded and followed him to the door.

Yuan suddenly stopped at the door and spoke, "Oh, right. I don't really care if you reveal my identity as Yuan since I no longer have any reason to hide it, but if you do... Let's just say that the public won't be very happy once they learn about Yu Tian's past."

Yuan and Meixiu left the Yu Family's manor shortly after.

Meifeng stayed in the room with Yu Yong and Tang Lee for a little longer.

After a long moment of silence, Meifeng bowed to them and said, "Despite all of the troubles you've caused me and others, I am still grateful towards the Yu Family.."

"Because of you, I was able to meet an amazing person like the Young Master, who I treated as my own son at one point. I'm sure that my daughter would agree with me, so I would like to thank you for that."

"However, it is time for me to leave the Yu Family. Once again, thank you for everything."

After giving them another bow, Meifeng turned around and walked out of the room.

She immediately went to pack her necessities and left the Yu Family shortly after.

Sometime later, she took a taxi and disappeared somewhere.

Meanwhile, Yuan and Meixiu regrouped with Chu Liuxiang.

"Is everything finished?" Chu Liuxiang asked.

"No, it's not. However, I don't want it to end so quickly, so I am going to take this slowly." Yuan said.

"Want to tell me about it? I won't force you if you don't want to." She then asked.

"I'll tell you as we move."

"Where are we going now?"

"The Cultivators' Association."

"Huh?" Chu Liuxiang raised her eyebrows.

"I have some people waiting for me there. You'll understand after you listen to what happened."

Thus, they started making their way towards the Cultivators' Association. Yuan would explain the situation to Chu Liuxiang on the way there.

"I see... So that's what happened... What are you going to do to those investors? Don't tell me you're really going to work with them."

"Of course not. They're just as guilty as the Yu Family for supporting them. In fact, they might even be the root of the whole problem. If they never approached the Yu Family, perhaps they wouldn't have been so corrupted." Yuan said.

"That makes sense. The investors are usually the real masterminds, as they are always pressuring those they support for more profit, even threatening them. The Chu Family had their fair share of trouble with them when I was there. That's just how the world works." Chu Liuxiang agreed with him.

"Yuan, do you think my mother will come with us?" Meixiu suddenly asked with a look of uncertainty on her face.

"Who knows." He shrugged.

"However, I do hope that she works for us."

"Me too..." She sighed.

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Chapter 991 - Until the Interview

Chapter 991 - Until the Interview

At the Cultivators' Association, Chairman Lee was surprised when David Swanson and the other investors suddenly showed up at his place.

"What the hell happened to you guys? Especially you, Mister Jiang. Your leg seems to be injured." Chairman Lee asked them with a frown on his face.

"Ah, I fell down on my way here. It's nothing serious." Mister Jiang said with a stiff smile on his face.

"Yu Tian told us to come here and wait for Player Yuan to show up. He promised that he will let us meet Player Yuan." David Swanson said.

"Come to my room now. All of you." Chairman Lee said.

Sometime later, once they were in a private room and sitting down, Chairman Lee slammed the table in anger, "TELL ME! WHAT HAPPENED BETWEEN YOU GUYS AND YU TIAN!?"

The investors were taken aback by Chairman Lee's sudden fit of rage.

"C-Calm down, Chairman Lee. Why are you so angry?" Mister Joe said to him.

"Calm down?! Do you idiots have any idea who you're messing with?!"

"We know. He knows Player Yuan, so it would be a bad idea to offend him. However, it's a little too late for that..."

"Tell me everything!" Chairman Lee frowned.

The investors looked at each other, seemingly hesitant to tell Chairman Lee about their involvement with the Yu Family and Yu Tian.

However, since they have somewhat dragged Chairman Lee into this mess and angered him, they had no choice but to tell him.

Even though they were all wealthy and powerful people, they did not dare to offend the Cultivators' Association that was getting increasingly more influential and powerful at a rapid rate, not to mention their relationship with the government.

Even before the investors finished telling the full story, Chairman Lee was already fuming in anger, his body trembling nonstop.

The investors were terrified when they saw this, and they wanted to stop, but they didn't dare to stop until they finished telling the whole story.

"You fucking idiots!" Chairman Lee shouted at them afterward.

"Chairman Lee, please tell us what you know. You clearly know something that we don't!" David Swanson said to him in a pleading voice.

However, before Chairman Lee could even say anything, someone knocked on the door.

"Chairman Lee! Someone claiming to be Player Yuan has asked for an audience!"

"What?! Player Yuan actually came?!" The investors were pleasantly surprised.

"Let him in!" Chairman Lee said.

The door opened, and three figures entered the room.

"You're..." The investors were puzzled when they saw Yuan. The thought that he was Player Yuan didn't even enter their minds.

"Where's Player Yuan? You promised us that we'd meet him!" One of them exclaimed.

"Of course, and I have already fulfilled that promise." Yuan said with a profound smile.

"W-What are you talking—" That person halted his sentence midway, and the entire room turned dead silent.

Chairman Lee suddenly stood up and bowed, "How are you doing, Yuan?"

When the investors heard Chairman Lee addressing him as 'Yuan', they all realized the truth almost simultaneously.

"Y-You're Player Yuan?! That's impossible!" David Swanson exclaimed, his face filled with disbelief.

"Don't tell me you're going to ask for proof again? I don't have the energy to deal with your nonsense anymore."

"Hmm? These guys... Aren't you Mister David?" A familiar voice suddenly resounded.

Yuan and everybody in the room turned to look at Chu Liuxiang.

"You know him?" Yuan asked her.

"Of course. I have seen him at the Chu Family plenty of times." She nodded.

"Y-Y-You are! Young Lady Chu! What are you doing here?!" David Swanson also recognized Chu Liuxiang after looking at her face closely.

The other investors there also recognized her.

As one of the most powerful and wealthy backgrounds in the country, it was only natural for these investors to approach the Chu Family.

"Is it weird for me to be here?" Chu Liuxiang said.

"W-What about the Chu Family?!"

"Oh, I left the family long ago. I am now part of his family." She pointed at Yuan.

"S-Seriously? You left the Chu Family to be with Yu Tian?"

"People may know him as Yu Tian, but I have always known him as Yuan."

Chu Liuxiang suddenly narrowed her eyes, "Anyways, I heard about the situation from him. So you guys are involved with the Yu Family, huh? Why am I not surprised?"

The investors began sweating.

If even someone like Chu Liuxiang decided to leave the Chu Family for him, there was no way they could refute his identity as Yuan anymore.

"Please forgive us, Yu Tian— No, Yuan!" David Swanson fell to his knees and kowtowed to Yuan.

The other investors immediately followed.

"Hahahaha!" Yuan suddenly started laughing.

"You want me to forgive you after everything that you've done to me?! In your damn dreams!"

The investors began taking steps back, distancing themselves from Yuan.

"Don't worry, I won't kill you. Once I am done with the Yu Family, I will deal with you guys as well."

"D-Deal with us?! You may be famous, but do you have what it takes to handle us?! You're just a damn child! What can you do besides threatening us with harm?!" Mister Jiang suddenly shouted.

Yuan smiled and said, "I may be a child, but I can destroy all of you with a few words."

"Oh? I would love to see how you're going to achieve that!"

Yuan smiled and turned to look at Chairman Lee.

"Chairman Lee, can you prepare an interview for me? I'd like to speak with the world for a moment."

"Of course. I will have everything prepared in an hour."

Yuan looked at the investors and spoke, "I will give you all a chance to live a normal life. If you give me all of your money, I will forgive you."

"All of our money?! You must be out of your damn mind!" David Swanson shouted.

Yuan shook his head and said, "Don't be so rash. I'll give you until the interview begins to give me the money."

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Chapter 992 - Removing His Mask

Chapter 992 - Removing His Mask

An hour passed in the blink of an eye.

Since then, Chairman Lee not only prepared the interview but also spread news that Player Yuan will be the one doing the interview.

When news spread, people from all over the city flocked to the Cultivators' Association, filling up the square outside almost immediately.

"Wow, there's a lot of people— more than I anticipated." Yuan looked at the crowd outside through the window.

"W-What are you planning?" David Swanson asked him in a nervous voice.

Yuan smiled and said, "You're right. I don't have the power to deal with you guys. After all, I am just one person who happens to be really good at a video game. However, what if I make those with power deal with you guys?"

He turned to look at the crowd again and continued, "I wonder how many Legacy Families are in that crowd? I also wonder what they would be willing to do for me if I offer them Divine-rank cultivation techniques and Divine-grade treasures?"

"Y-You're going to bribe them?!" The investors were in disbelief.

"No, I am only giving them a reward for helping me out. I guess you can even say that I am merely hiring them for a service. Once I give them your names, I wonder how long it will take for them to destroy you guys."

Yuan showed them a cold smile.

"If Divine-grade treasures are not enough, I can even offer them Ancient-grade treasures!"

"A-Ancient-grade treasures?!" They exclaimed.

In this world, besides Yuan, nobody has managed to acquire Ancient-grade treasures. In fact, besides a lucky few, even Divine-grade treasures are unobtainable.

The investors there looked at each other with fearful looks on their faces.

If Yuan was truly planning on bribing the public to destroy them, they would have no chance of survival! After all, even they would do everything in their power to help Yuan if they had the chance!

"Yuan, the interview is ready. You can go onto the stage whenever you want." Chairman Lee suddenly entered the room and said.

"Alright, I'm coming." Yuan wore a mask on his face before approaching the door.

"W-Wait! I am willing to give you all of my fortune!" One of the investors there suddenly stepped forward and announced.

"M-Me too! I will also give you every penny in my bank account!" Another stepped forward.

In their eyes, even if they gave away all of their money, there was still a chance for them to earn more money. However, if Yuan successfully bribes the world to destroy them, they might not survive through the rest of the week!

In the end four out of the twelve investors there decided to hand Yuan all of their money in order to purchase his forgiveness. As for the other eight, they refused to believe that Yuan would be able to bribe the public, as that would destroy his reputation.

"No more takers? Alright, don't say I didn't give you a chance later!"

Yuan walked out of the room shortly after with Chairman Lee.

Once they were alone, the investors there argued amongst themselves.

"Why did you agree to give him all of your money?! There's no way that he would be able to bribe the public! As if the other families would be that stupid to agree to such a thing!"

"I'm not taking that risk!"

"Even if he successfully bribes the public, he would immediately become the world's number one enemy! A single person shouldn't be able to hold that much power! The others will crush him before he can crush us!"

While the investors argued, Yuan appeared in the square and stepped on a portable platform that had just been prepared.

"Look! It's Player Yuan!"

"Damn it! He's still wearing a mask!"

"Is he the real deal or just a fake?"

"The Chairman of the Cultivators' Association is the one who organized this event... I don't think they would do something like this if he was a fake."

The crowd murmured amongst themselves.

"Hello, everyone. I am Chairman Lee of the Cultivators' Association. First of all, I would like to thank you all for coming here on such short notice. Second, I would like to thank Player Yuan for his participation despite his busy schedule." Chairman Lee took the microphone and spoke to the crowd.

After talking for a few more minutes, Chairman Lee handed the microphone to Yuan.

The entire place turned dead silent as they anxiously waited for him to speak.

This was happening all over the world, as the interview was being broadcast to the whole world.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan spoke into the microphone.

"Thank you all for coming today. Before I start, I would like to apologize for not appearing before all of you sooner, but I had a reason for hiding myself, and I am going to tell you all that reason today."

"Due to some family issues and health issues, I was unable to come out until today. I was born with a healthy body, but my body would stop functioning properly as I grew older."

"I lost my ability to see when I was only seven years old. When I was 13 years old, I became a cripple that couldn't even get out of bed without the help of another person, and for the next few years, I would remain in such a state."

"I am currently 18 years old, almost 19, and I have been living in solitude for almost 5 years now, hence why I am only appearing in public now."

The people watching Yuan's speech were left speechless after learning about his tragic life, and they all understood why he hasn't shown himself for so long.

"W-Wait... What the hell is he doing? What happened to bribing the public? Why does it seem like he's going to reveal his true identity?!" The investors watching from inside the Cultivators' Association were shocked.

Yuan continued speaking, "Now that I have completely recovered, I am going to celebrate by finally revealing my true identity to all of you today."

Everyone watching swallowed nervously after hearing his words.

Player Yuan is finally going to reveal his true identity? This is what everyone and their mother has been waiting for since the day of his first

appearance in the form of an announcement in Cultivation Online!

And without any hesitation, Yuan removed his mask, revealing to the world his handsome face.

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Chapter 993 - Player Yuan's True Identity

Chapter 993 - Player Yuan's True Identity

After removing his mask, Yuan placed it on the table in front of him and stared at the crowd with a calm expression.

It was almost as though the world was silent at this moment, as not a single sound could be heard from that location.

"Huh? That's Player Yuan? Doesn't he seem familiar? It's like I have seen him before..."

Some of the people there felt familiarity after seeing his face.

"W-Wait! I-Isn't that Yu Tian?! The legendary music prodigy who recently performed in a concert after disappearing for many years?! I am sure of it! That's Yu Tian! I even watched his performance a few days ago!"

Someone there finally recognized Yuan's face and exclaimed, letting everyone there know of his identity.

Yuan smiled and said, "Indeed, I am that Yu Tian."

The crowd became chaotic after this shocking revelation.

Nobody there could've expected the mysterious Player Yuan to be the missing child prodigy, Yu Tian!

Shortly after Yuan revealed his true identity as Yu Tian, people from all around the world started contacting the Yu Family. However, there was no

response from the Yu Family, almost as though they had suddenly disappeared.

Sometime later, Yuan's voice resounded again, "I am sure that some of you are trying to contact the Yu Family even as I am speaking, but I must warn you— you're only wasting your effort."

"Why would you say that, Yu Tian?!" One of the reporters there asked him.

Yuan glanced at the person who just spoke and responded in a cold voice, "Don't address me with that name. I don't want to be associated with that family."

The people there trembled after hearing his cold voice.

"D-Did something happen between you and the Yu Family? Would you be willing to tell us about it?!" Another reporter there asked.

"Of course. That's why I am doing this interview. I am going to answer as many questions as I can." He nodded.

"Anyways, the reason why I don't want to be associated with the Yu Family is because..."

Yuan proceeded to tell the whole world about how the Yu Family had mistreated and abused him since he was a child, treating him as though he was a slave for their own profit.

He told them about how the Yu Family had adopted him only to profit from his talents. He told them about how they would force him to practice day and night without any breaks. He told them about how they forced him to sign an illegal contract when he was still a young child. He told them about how they abandoned him after he became a cripple and how they treated him like trash since then.

When the world learned of all the horrible things the Yu Family had done to him, everyone felt anger in their hearts, and they cursed the Yu Family inwardly.

After talking about all of the bad things the Yu Family had done to him, Yuan started talking about the good things.

He spoke about how his younger sister had sacrificed herself so that she could take care of him for many years despite being two years younger than himself. He spoke about a certain servant who treated him like her own child.

Even though he wanted to drag the Yu Family through dirt, he didn't want those who helped him to be dragged along merely because of their association with the Yu Family, so he spoke about Yu Rou and Meifeng, treating them as though they were his savior.

This way, nobody would dare to mess with them even if they were associated with the Yu Family.

In fact, Yuan even publicly announced that if anyone were to mess with Yu Rou or Meifeng, they would face his wrath.

"Brother..." Yu Rou, who was watching the broadcast with Xia jingyi and White Lotus, bawled her eyes out.

Even though her own family had been exposed for their behavior and will soon be the public's number one enemy, she couldn't help but feel as though a mountain had been lifted from her shoulders.

Sometime later, Yuan said, "Although I want to blame all of my suffering on the Yu Family, that wouldn't be fair, as they were only manipulated by the true masterminds—"

"Oh no! This bastard is going to get us killed!" The investors finally realized Yuan's true intentions, but it was already too late.

Yuan proceeded to name the eight investors that refused to renounce their fortune for his forgiveness and spoke about how they had corrupted the Yu Family, even mentioning the companies they owned.

Immediately after Yuan revealed their names, the named investors started getting phone calls from pretty much everybody on their contact list and more.

"Mister Swanson! It's a disaster! Most of our investors and associates have just announced that they will stop supporting us and even demanded for their money back! At this rate, we'll go bankrupt!"

"Mister Jiang! Please! You need to do something! The Legacy Families are suddenly threatening to destroy us! What is happening?!"

When the four investors that renounced their fortune for Yuan's forgiveness saw the results of their decision, they all sighed in relief, feeling as though they'd just dodged a massive bullet, even though they will soon be losing all of their money.

"Fuck! That fucking bastard! We're ruined!" The eight investors cried, but there was nothing they could do about the situation.

However, Yuan wasn't done just yet.

"Although I cannot do anything against these people that have wronged me by myself, I would like to seek your help. If you can do something about it, please help me get justice. I will owe you a favor— you have my word."

When the powerful families that have been wanting to recruit Yuan heard the last few words of his sentence, they all decided to help him.

"This guy is freaking brutal!" Chairman Lee was sweating buckets as he stood behind Yuan, realizing how lucky he is to not be Yuan's enemy.

Chapter 994 - End of Yuan's Interview

Chapter 994 - End of Yuan's Interview

After dealing with the Yu Family and the eight investors, Yuan decided to answer some of the public's questions.

"I will now be answering any questions you may have."

All of the reporters there immediately started shouting their questions. It was so chaotic and loud that nobody could hear a proper question being asked.

"Please calm down. Since everyone here seems to have a question, I will pick some of you." Yuan said.

Once the place was quiet again, Yuan randomly pointed at someone in the crowd.

"The young man wearing a yellow shirt with a red heart. Do you have a question for me?"

"Y-Yes! Thank you for picking me! I want to ask— are you still playing Cultivation Online? A lot of people seem to think that you've quit for some reason."

"Of course I am still playing Cultivation Online. In fact, I intend on ascending to the next realm after I return home from all this."

The audience were shocked to hear such news because if Yuan manages to clear the Stairway to Heaven, the Third Heaven will be unlocked for all

players.

"Next question. The young lady wearing a red shirt and blue jeans." Yuan picked another person shortly after.

"Thank you for picking me! I would like to ask— what is your current cultivation in Cultivation Online and out here?"

Yuan smiled and said, "In Cultivation Online, I am at the peak of Spirit Lord. As for my current cultivation... I am a Spirit Grandmaster."

"What?! He's already achieved Spirit Grandmaster?!"

Everyone watching was in disbelief.

"If you don't believe me then let me show you something..." Yuan's body suddenly started hovering towards the sky, shocking everyone there, including Chairman Lee.

"H-H-He's flying?!"

"How is that possible?!"

"Is this a magic trick?!"

The reporters there asked him.

"Once you achieve Spirit Grandmaster, you can start learning something called Qi Manifestation. If you master this technique, you will be able to fly. This is also true in Cultivation Online."

Most people already knew that Spirit Grandmasters could fly without flying swords in Cultivation Online, but they didn't think it would also work in the real world.

Once the crowd calmed down, Yuan continued to answer their questions.

An hour later, Yuan said, "I will be ending the interview now. Thank you all for participating."

However, before leaving, he still had a surprise for everyone there.

After taking a deep breath, he spoke into the microphone, "In order to celebrate this occasion, I would like to host a little event, and anyone can participate in this event."

"Seven days from now, I will hide some Heaven-grade treasures and even a Divine-grade treasure in Spirit Heaven. If you can find it, it will be yours. I will give you the general location of the treasures on the same day. Good luck, everybody."

Yuan walked away from the platform and entered the Cultivators' Association with Chairman Lee while the guards there blocked the reporters from bombarding them.

After returning to the room with the investors, Yuan looked around and asked, "Where are the others?"

There were only four people left inside the room, and they were the ones who agreed to give Yuan their wealth.

"They all left long ago... If you had mentioned my name during the interview, I would've left too..."

"I see... Anyways, you have until tonight to hand me all of your wealth. If I find out that you didn't give me all of your money, I will do another interview. And don't even try running away because I will find you. Once you transfer the money, I don't want to ever hear from you or see you guys again. Do you understand me?"

"Y-Yes! We understand!" They all shouted.

Once Yuan handed his bank account to them, the four of them ran away.

"Now I don't need to worry about having no money for a while." Yuan smiled once he was alone with Chairman Lee.

"You'll probably have enough for more than one lifetime with the amount of money you're going to be getting later..." Chairman Lee shook his head

with a bittersweet smile.

"Thanks for your help, Chairman Lee. This wouldn't have been possible without your help."

"I will be glad to help you at any time! If you need help again, you know where to find me."

"I will send you a location in seven days. Go there and you will find something. No need to thank me. This is my way of thanking you." Yuan said to him.

"T-Thank— Okay!" Chairman Lee nodded with excitement.

Sometime later, he flew away from the Cultivators' Association since the outside was still flooded with people.

A few blocks away, he met up with Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang.

"Now that the entire world knows your true identity, what are you going to do?" Chu Liuxiang asked him.

"The same as usual," he said with a smile.

"I still can't believe you actually went through with it. I wonder how the Yu Family is doing now. I doubt they'll be able to survive after this scandal."

"They'll probably go into hiding." Meixiu said.

"They can hide all they want— as long as they give me back my money." Yuan said.

"Hey, Yuan, since we have some time now, let's go visit the orphanage!" Chu Liuxiang suddenly suggested.

"The orphanage...?" Yuan repeated in a mumbling voice.

"Yes! It's not that far from here, too!"

"Sure. Let's go." Yuan nodded with a smile.

They started making their way to the orphanage while the rest of the world talked about Yuan's interview today.

Meanwhile, at Eternal Lotuses, White Lotus and the others were busy refusing people that were trying to get into contact with Yu Rou after learning about her relationship with Yuan.

As for the Yu Family, their headquarters was surrounded by people that were throwing trash among other stuff into their property.

The police did not bother stopping these people because they didn't receive any complaints, and they also wanted justice for Yuan.

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Chapter 995 - Orphanage

Chapter 995 - Orphanage

An hour later, Yuan arrived at the orphanage that he and Chu Liuxiang used to call home.

"Wow, this place looks worse than it does in my memories..." Yuan was surprised by the poor condition of the place.

"Well, it's been over a decade since we lived here, and this place never had any money to begin with." Chu Liuxiang said.

And she continued in a sighing voice, "Even though the Chu Family had offered to give them donations multiple times, they would always refuse it."

"Why would they do that?"

"I have no idea." She shook her head.

"So this is where you two came from..." Meixiu was focused on the orphanage, as she considered this place as Yuan and Chu Liuxiang's true origins.

"Let's see if they are still in service." Yuan said a moment later.

They approached the worn building and knocked on the door.

A few moments later, the door opened, and a middle-aged woman appeared before them.

"How may I help you fine ladies and gentleman?" The middle-aged woman asked them with a gentle smile.

Yuan's eyes widened when he saw this woman's face, and he muttered in a low voice, "Sister Ellis...? Is that you?"

"Hm? Do I know you, handsome young man?" The middle-aged woman asked with a puzzled face.

"It's me, Yuan. Do you remember me? I used to play the harmonica all the time for you and the other orphans."

The middle-aged woman's eyes widened with surprise after hearing his words.

She covered her mouth and spoke in a trembling voice, "Y-Yuan...? Is that really you? My god... you've grown into such a fine young man... I couldn't recognize you at all!"

"Sister Ellis, what about me? Do you remember me?" Chu Liuxiang spoke next.

Ellis turned to look at her.

"Lulu? You look almost the same as the day you left. Your beautiful hair and hazel eyes— it's hard to forget about you even if I want to, especially since you were always the loudest one."

She turned to look at Meixiu next and asked, "Were you also from this orphanage? Sorry, but I don't recognize you."

"No, I am not." Meixiu quickly shook her head.

"I see... Anyways, what brought you two back to the orphanage?" Ellis asked them a moment later.

"We're just visiting," said Chu Liuxiang.

"How are you and the orphanage doing nowadays, Sister Ellie? If there's anything we can do to help..." Yuan asked her.

"Unfortunately, the orphanage is no longer in service. In fact, we shut down just last week. I am still here just to finish closing this place down."

"What?! The orphanage is no longer in service?! What happened?" Chu Liuxiang exclaimed.

"Well, we ran out of money, so we can no longer operate."

"Seriously? My father told me that he'd tried donating to your orphanage, but you guys would always refuse. Is there a reason why even though you clearly needed the money?"

Ellis sighed and said, "The owner of the orphanage is a corrupt bastard. Any money that gets donated to this orphanage will be stolen by him, so I refused the Chu Family's donation, as I don't want to give him any more money even if it means shutting this place down."

"..."

Yuan and Chu Liuxiang frowned after learning the truth.

"Who is the owner of this place? I want to have a word with him." Yuan said.

"What? I appreciate your thoughts, but there's no point in doing that. The orphanage is already closed. Furthermore, the owner sold it. This place will be demolished soon. There is nothing you or I can do about it."

"We won't know for sure until we try it. I made a small name for myself, so I should be able to help. Please, Sister Ellie. I don't want this place to disappear in such a manner." Yuan said in a dispirited manner.

Ellie sighed.

"All right. I will give you the name of this person. Just don't do anything rash, okay?"

"Of course." Yuan nodded with a smile.

Ellie handed him a business card that had all of the information they needed on it.

"Thank you. Give me a moment while I make a call." Yuan took the business card and proceeded to call Chairman Lee.

"Hello, Chairman Lee. If you don't mind, I'd like to trouble you again."

"What happened?"

"You see..."

Yuan began telling Chairman Lee about the situation and the owner's information.

"How dare this scoundrel steal money from an orphanage that helps children? Unforgivable! Don't worry, I will make sure he's taken care of before the day ends!"

"Thank you."

After hanging up, Yuan returned to Ellis.

"Sister Ellis, if you had the chance, would you become the new owner of this orphanage?" He suddenly asked her.

"Well... It's always been my passion to help those in need, especially children... If I can manage the orphanage, I would definitely do it. Why are you asking?"

"You will see in a bit." Yuan smiled.

"While we wait for the results, can we take a look around the building?" He then asked.

"Of course."

Yuan and the others followed Ellis into the orphanage shortly after.

"The interior is exactly like how I remember, but it's a lot smaller." Chu Liuxiang said.

"You're much bigger now so it's only obvious that this place would seem smaller." Ellis chuckled at her silly remarks.

"Hey! Yuan! Do you remember this spot? You would always sit on the table here and play the harmonica for us!" Chu Liuxiang pointed at an empty spot that used to have a table.

"I do, and you would always shake the table whenever you ask me to play another song." Yuan smiled.

Yuan and Chu Liuxiang would reminisce about their life as an orphan as they walked through the old and empty building.

Shortly after their tour ended, Chairman Lee called Yuan to let him know of some good news.

"I see... Thank you very much, Chairman Lee. I will return this favor in seven days." Yuan said to him.

After hanging up, he turned to look at Ellis with a wide smile on his face.

"Yuan...? What's the matter?" She asked in a nervous voice.

Chapter 996 - Personal Maid

Chapter 996 - Personal Maid

"I have some good news, Sister Ellis. This place will no longer be demolished, and you will become the new owner." Yuan relayed this news to her.

"What?! How is that possible? What did you do?" Ellis didn't dare to believe such good news.

"I just called a friend who could help us."

"B-But this place was already sold! How did they manage to convince the buyer?"

"Who knows." He shrugged.

"What about the previous owner? What happened to him?"

"He will be going to jail."

"W-What about the funds? Even if I own this place, if I don't have any money..."

"That's also been taken care of. I will be donating some of my money to this orphanage so you don't have to worry about money for a long time."

"Y-You? I don't want to put such a burden on you..."

"It's fine. I won the lottery recently, so I have plenty of money." Yuan chuckled.

"Seriously...?" Ellis stared at Yuan's calm expression with a shocked face.

"Seriously." He confirmed.

"My god..."

"By the way, there will be someone here later to help you get everything settled. They will also assist you until you can manage this place properly."

Tears began pouring out of Ellis' eyes.

"T-Thank you... How can I ever repay you for this...?"

"You already have." Yuan smiled.

Yuan and the others stayed with Ellis until the help Chairman Lee sent had arrived.

"Hello, I am Peter, and these people behind me are my team. We will be helping you get this orphanage back up and running as soon as possible. We will also teach you how to manage the place." The man leading the group introduced himself.

"Then we'll be leaving now, Sister Ellis. We'll come back later to check up on you." Yuan said to her.

After saying their goodbyes and hugging Sister Ellis, Yuan and his group left the orphanage.

"You're very lucky to have such a close relationship with him, Sister Ellis." Peter said to her after they left.

"Huh? Why?"

"You don't know?"

"No..."

Peter proceeded to tell Ellis about Yuan's background, which greatly shocked her.

"Oh my... To think he'd lived such a horrible life after leaving the orphanage... But I'm really glad that he's managed to turn his life around." Ellis sighed.

At the end of the day, Yuan asked Meixiu, "What's the situation with our money?"

She looked at their bank account and said, "The four investors have already sent their money. We currently have 122 billion dollars in the bank. However, we haven't received anything from the Yu Family yet."

"I see..." Yuan sighed.

"Are you going back to deal with the Yu Family?" Chu Liuxiang asked.

"Knowing them, they probably already fled the city and went into hiding." He shook his head.

"So what are we going to do now? Look for them?"

"It's already getting late, so I'm not going to bother. They can run, but they won't be able to hide forever. We'll eventually find them, and when we do..." Yuan's eyes glinted with a killing intent.

Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang swallowed nervously.

"Let's go home for now." He said to them a moment later.

"Okay."

They took a taxi back to the Dragon Spiral Mountain.

A few hours later, they arrived at the bottom of the mountain.

"Welcome back, Young Master Yuan." The guards outside the gates greeted him.

"Hey. We're back."

"Young Master Yuan, there is actually someone waiting for you..." One of the guards suddenly said to him.

"Huh? Who?"

"It's me, Young Master." A familiar voice resounded beside them.

Yuan turned to look at this person.

A smile appeared on his face when he realized her identity.

"Miss Meifeng... Are you sure?" Yuan asked her.

"Of course. It's always been my dream to work for you after you joined the Yu Family, and this is still my dream," she said.

After taking a deep breath, she bowed to him and spoke in a nervous voice, "Young Master, I would like to work for you. Please hire me. I am even willing to work for free."

"Of course I will hire you." Yuan smiled.

"Thank you, Young Master. You will not regret it."

"Mother..." Meixiu mumbled.

Meifeng turned to look at her next.

"You don't have to worry about me. Just continue living your life as usual," she said.

'Mother doesn't know about my relationship with Yuan yet... Things will definitely become awkward later if I don't tell her soon...' Meixiu sighed inwardly.

Meifeng followed Yuan and the others up the Dragon Spiral Mountain until they arrived at their destination.

"So this is the Young Master's current home..." She mumbled in a dazed voice.

"Let's go inside." Yuan said.

By the time they entered the building, the members of the Demon Sealing Faction were already waiting by the door to greet them.

"Welcome back, everyone! I saw the news! I can't believe that you'd actually revealed your true identity to the whole world, Yuan!" Shi Lang said.

"It was going to happen eventually, so I might as well do it sooner." Yuan smiled.

"Who is this beautiful lady?" Wang Ming asked with his gaze looking at Meifeng.

"This is—"

"Good evening, everyone. I am called Meifeng, Meixiu's mother, and I will be working here as the Young Master's personal maid starting today." She introduced herself before Yuan could even say anything.

"M-Meixiu's mother?! No wonder why you look so familiar even though this is my first time seeing you..."

The members of the faction were shocked by her identity. However, as excited as they were about meeting Meixiu's mother, they were all wondering the same thing at this moment.

'Meixiu is already Yuan's woman, yet her mother will be serving him as his servant... Isn't this incredibly awkward? How will their relationship even work?'

"Miss Meifeng, let me show you around the place. There are plenty of spare rooms so you can pick your own room." Yuan said to her a moment later.

"Okay." She nodded.

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Chapter 997 - Room Inspection

Chapter 997 - Room Inspection

Once Meifeng left with Yuan to tour around the mansion, the rest of the people there turned to look at Meixiu.

"Meixiu, now that your mother is here... Are you going to be fine?" Wang Bingbing asked her.

She nodded, "It will be fine. She may be my mother, but I am an adult now, and we're no longer at the Yu Family. Nothing will change even with her presence here."

"Your mother seems like the serious type. She's like the complete opposite of you." Wang Ming said.

"She's very serious and strict when it comes to her work, but she is always perfect. It might take a while, but you will eventually get used to her."

"Is there anything we should be aware of about her? Like what might make her angry?"

Meixiu pondered for a moment before responding, "If anything, she hates lazy people, I guess. But I don't think any of you should worry about it. She's working for Yuan now, so she will probably change just like I did."

While Meifeng followed Yuan around the mansion, she asked him, "What do you usually do nowadays, Young Master?"

"Uhh... Miss Meifeng, do you think you can stop calling me Young Master? You're Meixiu's mother, so it feels a little weird to be addressed in such a manner by you, not to mention that I am no longer a little kid. You're

also no longer working for the Yu Family. You don't need to be so formal. Things are really relaxed around here."

"Even if you say that, what am I supposed to call you? I have called you Young Master for over 10 years now, and old habits are hard to change. Furthermore, even if I am not at the Yu Family, I am still working for you."

"Can't you just call me Yuan like everyone?"

"That feels wrong to me. I think I will continue to call you Young Master, after all."

Yuan showed a bittersweet smile and said, "Your demeanor reminds me of someone I know in Cultivation Online, but she's much more easy going than you, even a little silly at times."

"Anyways, to answer your question, I usually just train with the others in the morning before going into Cultivation Online."

"That's it? Just training and playing video games? What about the instruments? Did you return to playing them?"

"Occasionally, I play the zither. But other than that, I don't touch other instruments. Actually, I guess I also played the piano a couple of times for Yu Rou."

"Do you have no intentions of returning to the world of music? Your talents... It really would be a waste."

Yuan pondered for a moment before responding, "Now that the entire world knows Yu Tian and Yuan are the same person, I might do a concert once in a while to entertain my fans. However, I don't intend on profiting from it. I want people to be able to enjoy my music without needing to worry about not affording tickets."

"That's just like you, Young Master..."

Sometime later, Yuan showed Meifeng his room.

"This is my room. That room right there is Meixiu's room."

Meifeng entered his room the following moment and immediately started inspecting it.

"Young Master... This place is full of dust. Meixiu... What does she do nowadays? Why isn't she cleaning your room?" Meifeng had a frown on her face as she looked at the little amount of dust on her fingers.

Although Chu Liuxiang cleans their room, she's not a professional maid like Meixiu or Meifeng, so it was only natural that the room isn't sparkless.

"Meixiu doesn't work as my maid anymore. I have her handle the faction and the food. Other than that, she trains with us and mainly focuses on her cultivation."

"Young Master, you cannot live like this! With this much dust in the room, you could easily get sick! Starting today, I will be cleaning your room every day!" Meifeng declared.

Of course, the room wasn't as dirty as Meifeng made it sound, but even a speck of dust in the room is one too many for someone like her.

"I'm going to see Meixiu's room now." Meifeng said after a quick inspection of Yuan's room.

Normally, one would need permission to enter Meixiu's room, but this was Meifeng, her mother. Even Yuan didn't dare to stop her from entering.

A moment later, Meifeng entered Meixiu's room and started her inspection.

"At least she's keeping her own room clean." Meifeng couldn't find anything to complain about after the inspection.

The bed was neatly made, and the furniture in the room was sparkling clean.

However, Meifeng wasn't satisfied just yet, so she dug a little deeper, going into her clothes and such.

A few minutes later, when Meifeng reached Meixiu's bed, she noticed something was off and reached her hand underneath the bed mattress.

Yuan raised his eyebrows, wondering what she was doing.

"What's this?" Meifeng felt something like a box and pulled it out.

When she saw what was written on the box, her eyes widened with shock, and her hands even began trembling.

'B-Birth control pills?! Why the hell is she hiding such a thing?!' Meifeng cried inwardly.

She turned to look at Yuan in a stiff manner.

"Y-Young Master... Are you and Meixiu... by some chance... doing it?"

"About that..."

Yuan didn't expect for Meifeng to find out about his relationship with her daughter so soon, but now that the cat is out of the bag, he might as well tell the truth.

"Yes, we're partners. We were going to tell you later when the time was right, but I guess there's no longer any need for that." Yuan chuckled.

Meifeng turned to look at the box again.

'That girl... She really did it...'

A slight smile appeared on Meifeng's face.

She returned the box back to its original place and said, "Don't tell Meixiu about this. I want to hear it from her."

"I understand." He nodded.

Chapter 998 - Who Was Your First?

Chapter 998 - Who Was Your First?

Meifeng left Meixiu's room shortly after putting back her secret.

"How long have the two of you been going out?" She asked him as they continued the tour around the mansion.

"Not that long. It started shortly after we moved to this place," he said.

"Who made the first move?"

"Meixiu..."

"Is that so... It appears that she's changed more than I anticipated."

And she continued, "What about you, Young Master? What do you think of my daughter?"

"I love her very much." Yuan said without any hesitation.

Meifeng smiled, "Do you remember when I asked you the same question last time?"

"I do, and I was naive back then. However, I have changed."

"I can see that."

Sometime later, after seeing the whole mansion, Meifeng picked her own room.

"I want to live in this room." Meifeng said as she stood at the door on the opposite side of Meixiu's room in the hallway.

"If that's where you want to stay, I have nothing to say." Yuan nodded.

Meifeng moved all of her luggage into the room shortly after.

When Meixiu learned that her mother will be living in the room across from her, she felt a little nervous and worried because that could affect her nighttime activities with Yuan.

Everyone in the building gathered at the dining room later.

"Starting today, as the head maid of this place, I will be taking care of breakfast and dinner and cleaning the mansion. Although I am the Young Master's personal maid, if you ever need any help, don't hesitate to ask. As for your laundry, I will be doing 2 to 3 people a day throughout the week. If you wish to do your own laundry, just let me know."

"Thank you, Madam Meifeng." The others said to her.

The members of the Demon Sealing Faction proceeded to introduce themselves to her one by one.

Sometime later, everybody went back to their own rooms to rest as it was getting late.

Yuan and Meifeng stayed up a little longer to chat.

"What happened to the Yu Family afterward? Do you know?" She asked him.

"They ran away, and they still owe me my money." Yuan smiled.

"Who could've imagined that something like this would happen..." She sighed.

"This is karma. They deserved it."

"By the way, there is still something that I need to tell you, Miss Meifeng. It's about Cultivation Online and our world."

Yuan proceeded to tell her about the truth with Cultivation Online and their world.

"Seriously...? This sounds like something straight out of fiction." Meifeng was in disbelief.

"I know, but trust me, it's true. Have you ever played Cultivation Online?" He then asked.

"No, I never had the time."

"Your cultivation is also very low. What cultivation technique are you using?"

"Something the Yu Family gave me."

Yuan pondered for a moment and said, "I'm going to get you a new cultivation technique that is far more powerful. Fortunately, you didn't progress that far in your cultivation, or it will be very difficult for you to suddenly change cultivation techniques."

"Also, I want you to focus more on your cultivation starting now. It's going to be very important in the future."

"I will do as you say, Young Master." Meifeng nodded.

Once Meifeng retired to her room, Yuan also did the same.

"Does Meixiu's mother know about our relationship?" Chu Liuxiang asked him in bed.

"Not ours, but she knows about Meixiu and mine. I'll tell her when the time is right."

"All right. Let's go to sleep."

The following morning, Yuan was woken up by the sound of someone knocking on his door.

"Young Master, I am going to start clearing your room now. You can continue to sleep if you want." Meifeng's voice resounded.

"Huh? W-Wait—" Yuan tried to stop her.

However, Meifeng had already opened the door and entered the room with her cleaning supplies.

"Y-Young Master... What is the meaning of this?!" Meifeng was shocked to see Chu Liuxiang sleeping beside him on the same bed.

Yuan rubbed his eyes and sighed, "Sorry, Miss Meifeng. I should've told you this earlier. This is Chu Liuxiang. She's also my partner."

Meifeng stared at him with wide eyes as she tried to comprehend the situation.

"You have two partners?" She eventually understood the situation and asked for confirmation.

"Yes. I've known Chu Liuxiang before I even came to the Yu Family. She was at the same orphanage as me."

"I see..." Meifeng mumbled.

"You're not mad?" Yuan raised an eyebrow.

"Why would I be mad? Because you're dating two women at once? Because you thought I would think that you're betraying Meixiu?"

"Something like that... I think?"

Meifeng shook her head, "You're mature enough to know this so I will tell you. Meixiu was raised to be nothing more than a servant for you. So the fact you accepted her as your partner is already more than I can ask for, and

it's not weird for influential people such as yourself to have more than one wife."

Of course, Yuan already knew this because Meixiu had told him before.

"Anyways, I am going to start cleaning your room now. I won't make much noise, so you can go back to sleep if you want." Meifeng said to him as she started cleaning his room.

"I don't think I can go back to sleep anymore so I will just wake up," he said with a smile.

While Yuan changed out of his pajamas, Meifeng suddenly asked, "By the way, Young Master, I have a question."

"What is it?"

"Who was your first? Meixiu or Chu Liuxiang?"

"M-Meixiu..." He said in a low voice.

"I see..." Meifeng didn't say anything else and continued to clean his room, but there was a small smile on her face now.

As for Chu Liuxiang, she was still sound asleep.

After cleaning his room, Meifeng proceeded to clean the bathroom.

Meanwhile, Yuan went to do some light training.

Li Jinxi showed up shortly after to train with him. Eventually, everyone was in the training field.

Chapter 999 - New Member

Chapter 999 - New Member

After training, everyone gathered in the dining room, where breakfast was already prepared by Meifeng.

"Wow... Did you really cook all of this by yourself?" Wang Ming asked with a dazed look on his face as he stared at the table that was filled with many different dishes for breakfast.

"This seems like something that requires a full team of chefs to achieve..." Wu Zao mumbled.

"You're more amazing than I thought, Madam Meifeng." Wang Bingbing praised.

"If I cannot do this much, then I am not fit to be with the Young Master." Meifeng spoke calmly.

They started eating the food shortly after.

"God! This is so freaking good! This is even better than what that old man at the Silver Restaurant back home makes!" Xi Murong exclaimed as he stuffed the food inside his mouth.

The Demon Sealing Faction emptied all of the dishes on the table in less than half an hour.

After breakfast, Meifeng took all of the empty plates and went to clean them.

"Meixiu, is Xiuying almost here yet?" Yuan asked her.

"Yes, she texted me an hour ago that she was on her way here—"

Meixiu's phone suddenly started ringing.

After seeing the caller, Meixiu said, "Speaking of the devil."

"This is Meixiu," she answered the phone.

"I understand. We're coming out now."

Meixiu hung up a second later and said to Yuan, "She's outside right now."

"Great."

Yuan stood up and said, "Everyone, our new member is here. Let's all go greet her."

"Oh? To have two new residents back to back, it seems like the Demon Sealing Faction is finally growing!" Wang Ming said.

Sometime later, they went outside to greet the newest member of the Demon Sealing Faction, Wang Xiuying.

"Hello, Xiuying. Welcome to our humble home." Yuan greeted her with a friendly smile.

"You call this place humble?" Wang Xiuying stared at the mansion behind him with a dumbfounded look on her face.

After snapping out of her daze, she introduced herself to everyone there, "Good morning, I am Wang Xiuying. I used to work in my grandfather's hospital, but I am now here. If you need any medical attention, just let me know! I am also an Alchemist in Cultivation Online, so I can also concoct pills for you guys!"

The members of the Demon Sealing Faction introduced themselves after her introduction.

"Nice to meet you all!"

"Let me show you around. You can leave your luggage inside for now."
Yuan said to her afterward.

"Okay!"

Once Wang Xiuying left with Yuan, the others started talking about their new member.

"Wow, she's really pretty. As expected of Yuan." Wang Ming said.

"She seems very energetic, too." Wang Bingbing added.

"Do you know anything about her, Meixiu?" They asked her next.

"Yes, her grandfather took care of Yuan when he was bedridden. After we left the Yu Family, she took her grandfather's place and took care of Yuan for a while. She's a good friend."

"What about their relationship? Is she also his partner?" Hong Xiuquan asked out of curiosity.

"They don't have that kind of relationship. However, Wang Xiuying admires Yuan a lot, and she even claims to be his number one fan." Meixiu shook her head.

"Well, now that she's living with him, it probably won't be long before things happen." Shi Lang shrugged.

Meanwhile—

"Wow, this place is so much nicer inside. Not even five star hotels can compare to this." Wang Xiuying mumbled as they walked around.

"Yes, it's a nice place. We're lucky to live here." Yuan smiled.

After walking for some time, Wang Xiuying suddenly said, "By the way, I saw your interview."

"What did you think of it?" He asked.

"I don't know how to say it... I felt angry at the Yu Family for what they've done to you, but I am also relieved that you finally exposed them. How are they doing right now?"

"I don't know, they ran away and hid somewhere." He shrugged.

"I'm not surprised. They suddenly became the most hated family in the entire world, after all."

"Also, did you regain your vision? Your eyes regained their color, and it feels like you can see me with your eyes, not your divine sense."

"Yes, I regained my vision."

Wang Xiuying sighed after hearing his words, and then she said, "Oh, don't misunderstand. I am happy for you, but I have always dreamed about curing your illness."

"Thank you, Xiuying. Your thoughts are enough. However, I don't think you can call it an illness. I think it's more of a curse than anything."

"Curse?" Wang Xiuying raised her eyebrows.

"I know it sounds crazy, but I have something to tell you later. It's very important."

"Sure."

Once their tour was finished and Wang Xiuying picked her room that was on the same floor as Yuan's room, they sat down to drink some tea made by Meifeng.

"Eh? Miss Meifeng? What are you doing here?" Wang Xiuying was surprised to see her there.

"I am now working for the Young Master," she gave a quick and brief explanation.

"I see..."

As they enjoyed the tea, Yuan explained the situation with Cultivation Online to her.

"What?! Our soul?!" Wang Xiuying was shocked after learning the truth.

"Yes, so you shouldn't go too crazy in Cultivation Online, and try your best to not get hurt. Any damage done to your soul is incredibly severe.

"I-I understand... I will be less reckless with Alchemy now that I know there are real risks to getting hurt..." She swallowed nervously.

Sometime later, Wang Xiuying went to her own room to organize her luggage.

Meanwhile, Meixiu approached Meifeng.

"Mother, I need to speak with you privately whenever you're available."

"Meet me in my room in an hour," Meifeng said.

"Okay."

An hour later, Meixiu knocked on the door to Meifeng's room.

"Come inside."

After entering the room and closing the door behind her, Meixiu looked at her mother with a calm but serious expression, "There's something I need to tell you, and it's about my relationship with Yuan."

Chapter 1000 - Mother and Daughter

Chapter 1000 - Mother and Daughter

"I'm listening." Meifeng said as she stood in front of Meixiu.

Meixiu took a deep breath before speaking, "The truth is... I am currently in a romantic relationship with Yuan."

Meixiu stared at her mother's face to see her reaction.

However, to her surprise, Meifeng's facial expression remained unchanged, seemingly unfazed.

"I see. Congratulations." Meifeng said to her in a calm voice a moment later.

"Y-You're not surprised?" Meixiu swallowed nervously.

"Why would I be? I knew that it was going to happen eventually."

"Is that so..." Meixiu was a little disappointed by her mother's lack of reaction. She thought she would be able to surprise Meifeng, but alas, that did not happen.

"That's all I have to say." Meixiu turned around and began walking towards the door.

However, Meifeng stopped her, "Where do you think you're going?"

"You may have nothing left to say, but I haven't said anything yet."

Meixiu halted her movements and walked back to her original spot.

"Let's sit down first."

The two of them went onto the balcony and sat down before each other.

Once they were seated, Meifeng spoke, "I want to hear about your relationship with the Young Master. Start from the beginning."

"The beginning?" Meixiu raised her eyebrows in a questioning manner, as it was too vague.

"Start from the day you left the Yu Family with him." Meifeng clarified.

"Okay." She nodded.

Meixiu proceeded to recall her experience with Yuan from the day they left the Yu Family all the way until the present day.

After telling Meifeng everything, Meixiu did not stop and continued, "There's something else you should know about... Yuan has another partner..."

"Chu Liuxiang, right?" Meifeng said.

"Huh? You knew about it? How?"

"I learned about it this morning. In fact, I already knew about your relationship with Yuan since yesterday when I found the birth control pills hidden under your bed. What kind of sloppy hiding spot is that?" Meifeng revealed the truth to her.

"You searched my room?!" Meixiu was speechless.

"No, I inspected it. I wanted to make sure that you weren't slacking."

"Unbelievable..." Meixiu became silent.

A moment later, Meifeng spoke, "Let's get to the main topic."

"Main topic?"

"Yes. I want to know your plans. When are you going to bear his children?"

"B-Bear his children?! I am still too young for that kind of thing!" Meixiu exclaimed.

"Too young? You're already an adult. A lot of ladies from influential families start their own family at your age. In fact, I got pregnant with you at that age, too."

"Seriously...?" Meixiu couldn't believe her ears.

"Meixiu, listen to me. If you want to remain relevant in the family, you must bear his child. The Young Master will definitely accept more women into his life in the future, and when that happens, he will have less time for you."

"I am well aware of that, and I will eventually bear his child, but that time is not now. It's too soon, not to mention the situation with Cultivation Online."

"Well, it's not like I am forcing you to bear his child. I am merely giving you advice as your mother. In fact, you'll probably become pregnant by accident, anyway."

"W-What? Why do you sound so confident about that?"

"Because birth control pills are not perfect. Although the chances are slim, it's not impossible for you to become pregnant even if you take the pills, especially since you're not wearing rubber when doing it with him."

Meixiu swallowed nervously after hearing her mother's words. Will she really get pregnant by accident?

Meifeng then continued, "I don't know much about Chu Liuxiang, but she seems like a bold girl. She'll probably get pregnant before you at this rate—if she's not already pregnant."

"I don't want to talk about this anymore... I'm leaving." Meixiu stood up and quickly left the room.

'She may have matured, but she's still a child at heart.' Meifeng shook her head inwardly.

Meanwhile, Yuan entered Cultivation Online.

"Welcome back, Young Master."

"Good morning, Brother Yuan."

"Hey, I am finally back. Sorry to keep you all waiting, we'll start climbing the Stairway to Heaven soon. I have one last thing to do before then."

Yuan flew around Spirit Heaven and started hiding treasures in random places.

"W-What are you doing, Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang asked him in a puzzled voice.

"I'm hosting an event where I hide treasures for people to find," he calmly explained.

Feng Yuxiang was speechless. She had tons of questions, but she didn't dare to ask them.

While Yuan hid treasures around the world, the internet was going wild about the event.

[Player Yuan is hosting a massive event!]

[A chance to acquire Heaven-grade treasures for free!]

[Player Yuan's real identity has finally been revealed!]

[Yu Family's scandal!]

Pretty much the entire world was talking about Yuan's interview yesterday as well as the Yu Family's scandal.

At Eternal Lotuses, their front gate was swarmed with people trying to interview Yu Rou.

"Senior Bai, I would like to do an interview of my own." Yu Rou approached White Lotus with this request.

"Huh? Why?" White Lotus asked.

"I just think it's the right thing to do. I can't stay silent forever. I will also let the world know my side of the story," she said.

After pondering for some time, White Lotus agreed to Yu Rou's request, and the interview was scheduled to start in four hours.

News of Yu Rou's interview started spreading like wildfire after White Lotus revealed it to the reporters outside their faction.

Four hours later, Yu Rou started her interview, and she told the world about her experience with the Yu Family, confirming everything that Yuan had said during his interview.

Yuan watched the interview later that evening with Meixiu and Meifeng.

"That little girl... She's growing up so fast..." Yuan said with a sweet smile on his face.

"She handled it well. I haven't seen her in a while, but she's definitely matured a lot." Meifeng said in a praising voice.

Chapter 1001 - Not Ready

Chapter 1001 - Not Ready

The following morning during breakfast, Li Jinxi asked, "Yuan, now that you're back, are we going to start ascending to the next realm?"

"Yes, but I want to wait a few more days just in case anything happens. Once I start ascending, I will be staying in Cultivation Online until I finish all of the trials, so I want to make sure that nothing will distract me from it." He nodded.

"Makes sense."

"I don't think you need to worry. If anything happens, we'll be able to do something about it. We're here for you, after all. You can rely on us." Wang Ming suddenly said.

Yuan pondered for a moment before nodding his head, "You're right. I should rely on you guys more."

"All right, we're going to ascend tonight. Make sure you're prepared by then."

"Okay." The members ascending with him nodded.

"Young Master, may I have some of your time? I have something to ask you." Meifeng asked him after breakfast.

"Sure. Where do you want to talk?"

"We can do it in my room," she said.

Yuan nodded and followed Meifeng to her room.

After preparing some tea and serving it to him, Meifeng sat down before him.

"I'm ready when you are, Miss Meifeng." Yuan said to her.

"Thank you, Young Master. But to be honest, this isn't that serious, and the topic might not be what you expect."

Yuan raised an eyebrow as he wondered what she wanted to tell him.

After taking a deep breath, Meifeng spoke with a serious look on her face, "Young Master, what do you think about having a child with my daughter?"

Yuan was sipping his tea when Meifeng started speaking.

After hearing her question, he nearly spat out the tea in his mouth.

"A-A child with Meixiu? Where did this come from?" He asked her a moment later.

"As her mother, it's only natural for me to think about these things now that she's found herself the perfect partner. And to be completely honest with you, Young Master, I also want to see some grandchildren."

"I-I don't know what to tell you, Miss Meifeng... This is not something I can decide on. Furthermore, we don't have the time to take care of a baby, not to mention that things will only get busier as we get closer to unveiling the truth behind Cultivation Online and Earth."

"If you're worried about not having enough time, you don't need to worry because I can take care of the baby and do my work at the same time. I've already done so with both Meixiu and you, after all."

"Even if you say that... Have you spoken to Meixiu about this?" Yuan asked.

"I have."

"What's her answer?"

"She said that she's not ready."

"If she's not ready then there's nothing I can do. I won't force her to have a child with me if she isn't ready to have one." Yuan shook his head.

"I know, and I am not asking you to do so. However, if you ever feel like having a child with Meixiu, you will most likely have to be the one to convince her. Knowing her, she's probably waiting for you to approach her."

"I see... Then to tell you the truth, I also think I am not ready to have any children. I am still young, and there are many problems in my life that I need to sort out first before I can even start thinking about bringing another life to this world."

Meifeng closed her eyes and remained silent for a couple of moments before sighing, "Since the Young Master has spoken, I won't bother you with this matter anymore. Though, I would like to ask, how is your relationship with Chu Liuxiang? Judging by what I've seen from her, she seems like the type of girl to want a family as soon as possible."

Yuan smiled and said, "As expected of you, Miss Meifeng. Your eyes are as sharp as ever. Indeed, Lulu's dream is to have her own family. However, she hasn't asked me to do anything yet. She's also probably waiting for me to approach her, but who knows. She's sometimes very unpredictable."

"I understand. And I apologize for wasting your time with my little nonsense... Ever since Meixiu left with you, I have been thinking about having grandchildren, even though it's never happened before."

"Don't worry about it, Miss Meifeng."

"Also, you should stop calling me that. You're my Master now. You can just call me Meifeng."

"I can call you Meifeng, but you'll also have to drop the formalities and call me Yuan."

"That's not fair, Young Master..."

"Please. You're Meixiu's mother. It would be weird for my future mother-in-law to address me as Young Master."

"..."

Meifeng released a defeated sigh.

"I understand. If that's what you want, I shall obey... Yuan."

"Thank you, Meifeng." He smiled.

For the rest of the day, Yuan would work on his little treasure hunt. Once he made all preparations, he made his way to the Stairway to Heaven and waited for the others to show up.

When Meixiu, Chu Liuxiang, and Li Jinxi entered Cultivation Online, they all approached the Stairway to Heaven.

"We're finally going to ascend. I've been waiting for this moment!" Chu Liuxiang said in an excited voice as they approached the man handing out the badges.

"I'd like four badges." Yuan said to the man, who immediately raised his eyebrows.

"Four? Only one of you can challenge the Stairway to Heaven at a time," he said.

"I know. I am going to be the only one challenging the Stairway to Heaven. They're just coming along with me." Yuan smiled.

"Seriously? Are you aware that—"

"Yes, I am aware that by doing so, it would make the trials much harder, and I am prepared for it."

The man looked at the three beauties standing behind him and sighed in a low voice, "Statistically speaking, men that focus too much on women will never go far in the cultivation world. However, this is your life, not mine."

Once the old man handed four badges to Yuan, they immediately began climbing the staircase that led to the Stairway to Heaven.

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Chapter 1002 - Surrounded

Chapter 1002 - Surrounded

Once they arrived in front of the staircase, Yuan started climbing it while being pressured by an invisible force.

However, unlike the first time, he was not bothered by it at all. As for Meixiu and the others, they climbed the staircase without feeling anything.

"Is it supposed to be this easy?" Li Jinxi asked.

"No, it's not. Since we're not taking the trial, we won't need to do anything. However, Yuan will have to bear our share of effort, so it's going to be a lot harder on him than normal." Chu Liuxiang explained to her.

"What? If that's the case, why don't we just let him do it by himself? The Stairway to Heaven will probably open for everyone else after he clears it. There's no reason to make it harder on him for no reason." Li Jinxi said.

"He's probably already thought about that, but since he isn't saying anything, he probably wants the challenge. After all, it would be too easy if he went inside by himself." Chu Liuxiang shrugged.

"Will he be okay...?"

"Of course. He passed the last Stairway to Heaven while carrying three other people as well."

"Really? Who was the third one? And where is this person now?"

"He helped a fellow disciple from the same sect to escape her family. She joined one of the Seven Spiritual Academies with the others."

"I see..."

Sometime later, once Yuan and the others arrived before the grand doors of the Stairway to Heaven, they started inserting their badge into the slots.

However, right as Yuan prepared to insert his badge into the door, he suddenly stopped and started looking around.

"What are you looking for?" Chu Liuxiang asked him, but he didn't say anything.

"Feng Feng, Xiao Hua, Yingying." He suddenly called them.

The three of them appeared before him the next second.

"Protect them." He said.

"Yes."

"What's going on, Yuan?" Meixiu asked him with a slight frown on her face.

"We're surrounded."

"Huh? By who?" Chu Liuxiang looked around, but she couldn't see anyone.

Suddenly, a tremendous pressure that surpassed even the staircase Yuan climbed appeared.

Feng Yuxiang and Xiao Hua used their cultivation to protect Meixiu and the others.

"Where do you think you're going, Yuan?" A familiar voice suddenly resounded in the area.

Eight figures appeared in the air above them a moment later, all of them emitting the aura of a Spirit King.

Yuan smiled when he saw the person leading this group.

"I was wondering when you'll come back, Lord Ji. So, where did you go after disappearing without a word? What happened to my judgment?"

"Your judgment was a little unique, so I had to delay it."

"You couldn't have picked a better time? I'm finally about to ascend after many delays, and you're here to delay it again? It's almost as though this world is trying to prevent me from ascending for some reason."

"Hahaha!" Lord Ji suddenly started laughing.

He then spoke, "Don't worry, Yuan. This will be your last delay because you will not survive another day. If you're dead, you won't need to worry about being delayed or ascending."

"So you're going to kill me today? What happened to not meddling with outside affairs unless it breaks the balance of the world? Don't tell me that I am going to break the balance of the world by ascending?" He asked.

"Oh no, what you did is far worse than breaking the balance of this world." Lord Ji said.

"Since I am going to die today, can you enlighten me for a moment? What exactly did I do?"

Lord Ji pointed his sword at Yuan and spoke in a cold voice, "You offended the Heavens, that's what you did."

"I offended the Heavens? How and when did I do such a thing?" Yuan raised an eyebrow.

"That's something I wish to know as well."

"So you don't know how or if I even offended the Heavens, yet you're here trying to kill me? Can you be any more unreasonable?"

"I may not know how, but I definitely know that you have offended the Heavens. When I called upon Heaven's Judgment on you, the crystal

became pitch black. I didn't know what it meant at that time because I have never seen such a result before, so I went back home to check."

"After some research and much to my shock, I learned that when the crystal turns black after Heaven's Judgment, that means the Heavens wants you dead at all cost! Although it has never happened in the lower half of the Nine Heavens before, the crystal only turns black when someone has done something or is planning on doing something that will harm the Heavens!"

"Such a heinous crime cannot be fully rectified even with your death, so I am going to shatter your soul and erase your existence entirely! This is Heaven's judgment for you, Yuan!" Lord Ji declared.

And he continued, "Don't even try running away into the Stairway to Heaven. As the Lord of this realm, I have control over the Stairway to Heaven. You won't be able to open that door even if you put in your badge. There's nowhere to run."

"Is that so..." Yuan mumbled.

"Ahahaha!" A familiar-sounding laughter suddenly resounded.

"Yuan! I am finally going to get the chance to avenge my brother and my son! With the Seven Legacy Families and the Ji Family working together to take you down, not even the Heavens can save you today! Oh right! Even the Heavens want you dead!" Patriarch Gu, who was among the group of Spirit Kings, suddenly exclaimed in a spiteful voice, his aura filled with killing intent.

Indeed, the 7 individuals that Lord Ji brought with him were all leaders of their own Legacy Family from the Seven Legacy Families.

Right after Patriarch Gu's sentence ended, Yuan and the others could see a sea of people approaching them from all directions like a tidal wave. They were all people from the Seven Legacy Families and the Ji Family, and they were all there to carry out Heaven's Judgment by killing Yuan.

Chapter 1003 - Opening the Stairway to Heaven

Chapter 1003 - Opening the Stairway to Heaven

"Over 300,000 people have gathered here today just to kill you, Yuan. Don't you feel honored?" Lord Ji said with a cold smirk on his face.

"Yes, I'm a little flattered that you would go out of your way to send an entire army just for me. However, I will have to disappoint you. Your efforts will be in vain, and I will ascend the Stairway to Heaven just as planned." Yuan remained calm despite his seemingly hopeless situation.

"Nobody here can stop me from ascending today— not even the Heavens itself."

"Hahahaha! You're truly one crazy bastard, Yuan!" Lord Ji suddenly burst out laughing, his voice so powerful that it created ripples in the air.

"I know that you're a talented guy, but there are situations in this world that cannot be solved with talent alone, and this is one of them!"

"You're currently surrounded by the Seven Legacy Families and my Ji Family! Furthermore, your only way of escape— the Stairway to Heaven— is blocked! You have no chance of escaping today!"

"The Stairway to Heaven is blocked?" Yuan suddenly scoffed.

"Who decided that? The Stairway to Heaven isn't owned by you. If I want to open these doors, there is nothing you can do to stop me."

"While it is technically true that I do not own the Stairway to Heaven, as the Lord of this realm, I have the authority to choose who can open the door and who cannot! If you don't believe me, you may go ahead and try it!" Lord Ji said.

"I was going to do that even without needing your permission. However, let's also have some fun while we're at it. If I can successfully open the Stairway to Heaven, why don't you let us go?"

"Are you thinking about forcing your way inside the Stairway to Heaven? Not even Immortals who are near the peak of the cultivation world can force their way into the Stairway to Heaven, much less a Spirit Lord like you!"

"Who said anything about forcing my way inside? I am going to place my badge and open the Stairway to Heaven the normal way. If I can achieve that, promise me that you'll give up on trying to kill me."

Lord Ji narrowed his sharp eyes at Yuan, seemingly trying to figure out his true purpose.

Although he was confident that Yuan would not be able to open the Stairway to Heaven without his permission, he had an uneasy feeling in his guts.

"Why are you staying silent, Lord Ji? You don't seem very confident in your own words now." Yuan showed him a mocking smile on his face.

"There's no need to play your games because you'll be dead soon," Lord Ji sneered.

"Anyways, do you have any last words before we kill you?"

He nodded and asked, "What about my friends? Since I am your target, it wouldn't make sense to harm them. Why not let them go?"

"Unfortunately, those who are associated with a criminal like you also deserve the death penalty. Therefore, they are all going to die here with

you."

"That's not very reasonable. It's a pity. I thought you would be a little different from the rest of the villains." Yuan shook his head.

"Did you just call me a villain?" Lord Ji's face suddenly turned ice cold, almost as though he'd swallowed a live fly by accident.

"How dare you compare me with a villain! I am Heaven's servant, and Heaven is just! You, who dared to offend the Heavens, is the villain here!" Lord Ji roared with a twisted look on his face.

Clearly, Yuan had accidentally poked his reverse scale.

Yuan sighed, "Forget it."

And without even looking, Yuan inserted the badge into the main slot of the doors to the Stairway to Heaven.

However, the Stairway to Heaven had no reactions whatsoever.

The leaders of the Seven Legacy Families started to laugh out loud after seeing this.

"Look at this damn fool! It's like he's deaf or something! Lord Ji clearly told him that he would not be able to open the door!"

Yuan ignored them and knocked on the door.

"Umm... Tian'er, can you hear me? If you don't mind, I'd like to enter." He said out loud.

"Hahahaha!" Even the 300,000 people there started laughing out loud.

"What the hell does he think he is doing? Who the hell is Tian'er? Has he gone crazy?!"

However, in the midst of their laughter, the Stairway to Heaven suddenly started shaking.

The 300,000 people there, as well as Lord Ji and the leaders, stopped laughing and watched with wide eyes as the massive doors for the Stairway to Heaven started opening.

"Meixiu, Lulu, Jinxi, I want you to go inside and wait for me." Yuan suddenly said to them with a serious expression on his face.

"What about you? Why aren't you coming with us?" Meixiu asked with a worried frown.

"Don't worry, I will follow you guys once I speak with them some more."

"What if the door closes on you?" Chu Liuxiang asked.

"It won't happen. Trust me." He smiled.

"Alright, we'll wait for you inside. Don't take too long." Meixiu nodded.

They entered the Stairway to Heaven the next moment.

'What the hell is going on?! Why did the Stairway to Heaven open for him?! I specifically ordered it not to open for anyone today!' Lord Ji cried inwardly as he watched Meixiu and the others enter the Stairway to Heaven.

'Oh no! He's going to get away at this rate!'

"Stop him from entering the Stairway to Heaven at all cost!" Lord Ji suddenly shouted.

The leaders of the Seven Legacy Families immediately rushed at Yuan, who suddenly raised his hands and said, "Calm down, I don't intend on leaving just yet."

The Stairway to Heaven closed its doors the following moment.

Lord Ji sighed in relief after seeing that Yuan had remained, but he still couldn't understand why the Stairway to Heaven had opened just now.

Chapter 1004 - Heaven's Regulation

Chapter 1004 - Heaven's Regulation

"What the hell did you do just now? How did you open the Stairway to Heaven?" Lord Ji questioned Yuan after the shocking event.

"If you tell me why I am being hunted and I will tell you." He said.

"I already told you— I am only upholding Heaven's judgment. I don't know what you did, but I know that you must die."

"That doesn't really answer my question, so my question remains unanswered." Yuan shrugged.

"If you don't want to tell me, that's fine. You'll regret not leaving just now because that was your only chance to survive even a little longer!" Lord Ji smiled.

"Only a little longer? What can you do to me once I ascend to the Third Heaven?" Yuan raised an eyebrow.

"Hahaha! You're really foolish and ignorant! Do you really think that you'll be able to escape from punishment just because you escape to another Heaven? In case you forgot, my Ji Family exists in the other Heavens as well! As long as you remain alive, you will be hunted by the Nine Heavens!"

"Now you're telling me that I am going to be hunted by the Nine Heavens? That doesn't make any sense. You're making it sound like I am an Exile."

'Oh? So he knows about Exiles? How surprising.' Lord Ji appeared to be genuinely surprised that Yuan knew about Exiles, mostly because they are only ever mentioned in the upper heavens.

"I wouldn't compare myself to Exiles if I were in your shoes, Yuan. As an Exile, at least I can be pardoned by completing the Supreme Heaven's Legacy. However, your situation is different. There are no second chances — no opportunity for you to be pardoned! The Heavens have already dictated you as a dead man! No matter where you go in the Nine Heavens, you will be hunted by those who serve the Heavens!"

Yuan frowned upon hearing this.

He will be hunted no matter where he went in the Nine Heavens? What did he do to deserve such a punishment? Furthermore, even if he can defeat everyone here today, it will be much harder for him to ascend now that the entire world is suddenly against him.

"So you will kill me today no matter what, is that correct?" Yuan asked for confirmation.

"That's right." Lord Ji confirmed.

"Young Master, no matter what you did, even if the entire world is your enemy, I will forever be your loyal servant." Feng Yuxiang suddenly said to him in a calm voice.

"Xiao Hua will always be with Brother Yuan as well." Xiao Hua said.

"I swore my loyalty to you, Yuan. Even if the Heavens are against you, I shall fight by your side." Lan Yingying said.

Yuan smiled and said, "Thank you. I'm really glad to have the three of you by my side."

He then turned to look at Lord Ji and said, "As much as I want to kill everyone here for wanting to kill me, I am not that ruthless, so consider yourselves lucky."

Yuan knocked on the door to the Stairway to Heaven the next moment, causing it to open again.

"Let's go. There's no need to waste our time and effort on these idiots."

Lord Ji was shocked to see that Yuan had managed to open the Stairway to Heaven again, but he wasn't going to let Yuan enter like the girls.

He suddenly retrieved a golden medallion and activated his spiritual energy, "Heaven's Regulation!"

Yuan, who was only a step from entering the Stairway to Heaven, suddenly felt an immense pressure that even he could not resist, and he was immediately brought down to his knees.

"Young Master?!" Feng Yuxiang and the others were shocked to see Yuan in such a condition.

"I did not think I needed to use this treasure so early. However, since you were on the verge of escaping, I had no choice." Lord Ji said after taking a deep breath, feeling relieved that he managed to stop Yuan on time.

'What an immense pressure! What did he do to me?!' Yuan slowly turned his head to look at the medallion in Lord Ji's grasp.

Yuan's eyes widened when he saw the golden medallion. However, this was his first time seeing such an item. Despite that, he felt like he had seen it before, and he could feel something welling up inside him.

'This feeling...'

He recognized this emotion very well. It was the feeling of anger— intense anger that could burn even the Heavens, and the only time he would feel this kind of emotion is when the Evil God appears.

Yuan's eyes slowly started turning blood red as the insane amount of anger started pumping his heart with adrenaline.

"Heaven's Regulation... I will... destroy the... Heavens!" Yuan muttered in a low but resolute voice.

"DAMN HEAVENS' PUPPETS! I WILL DESTROY YOU ALL!"

Yuan suddenly released a deafening roar that caused a ripple that contained intense killing intent to appear, sweeping the area with his terrifying killing intent.

Everyone below Spirit Master coughed up a mouthful of blood and fell to the ground after experiencing Yuan's killing intent that came only from his voice alone.

"What happened?!" Lord Ji and the others were shocked by Yuan's surprise attack that instantly took down all of their Spirit Warriors and Spirit Apprentices, which added up to over 100,000 casualties.

A pair of beautiful yet ominous crimson wings suddenly sprouted from Yuan's back.

Lord Ji and everyone there were horrified when they saw the crimson wings created from killing intent. Even Xiao Hua and the other two couldn't help but tremble before the majestic wings that were drooling red miasma.

'How is it possible for someone to have so much killing intent?! Just how many people did he kill?!' Lord Ji cried inwardly after seeing Yuan's devil-like appearance, feeling a strong urge to turn around and run the opposite direction.

Yuan slowly stood back up and turned to look at Lord Ji with a cold glare that could freeze even the Yellow Springs of the dead.

"Heavens' puppet... You will regret showing your face before my presence."

Chapter 1005 - Fighting Lord Ji and the Seven Legacy Families

Chapter 1005 - Fighting Lord Ji and the Seven Legacy Families

"K-K-Kill them all!" Lord Ji commanded everyone there in a trembling voice.

The 200,000 remaining cultivators there started rushing forward.

Seeing this, Yuan turned to look at Feng Yuxiang and the others.

With a tranquil expression and a calm voice that could soothe even a crying baby, he spoke, "Leave nobody alive."

"With pleasure!" A wide smile appeared on Feng Yuxiang's face as she flew away from the staircase and towards the army to the west, leaving a trail of beautiful golden flames wherever she went.

Xiao Hua didn't say anything and flew towards the east. Once she was in front of the army, she retrieved two spiritual weapons that emitted an aura only Divine-grade treasures can emit.

As for Lan Yingying, she went in the direction where Lord Ji and the seven leaders were not present, leaving them to Yuan.

Once she was in the air, Lan Yingying transformed into a massive white serpent. The people there were greatly shocked by Lan Yingying's transformation.

"She was a magical beast this whole time?!"

"No! This divine aura around her— she's a Divine Beast!" Lord Ji exclaimed.

He couldn't believe his eyes. Why would a Divine Beast be with someone like Yuan, much less help him?

Once she reached the army, Lan Yingying opened her mouth and breathed scared flames on them like a dragon.

Everyone that was unfortunate enough to touch her sacred flames were instantly engulfed in her flames and burned until there was nothing left.

Meanwhile, Feng Yuxiang would cause explosions whenever she went, even creating a sea of flames with her Phoenix fire.

Xiao Hua would casually swing her spiritual weapons and kill over a dozen people with a single swing.

Terrified screams resounded in all directions and the 200,000 army quickly diminished.

It was a one-sided slaughter that left Lord Ji and the leaders of the Seven Legacy Families utterly shocked and terrified, and they all wondered what kind of background Yuan had to be able to do something like this.

However, they were also beginning to understand why the Heavens wanted him dead.

'The Heavens... Are they scared of his potential? He's only a Spirit Lord in the Second Heaven, yet he's already amassed such prowess...' Lord Ji wondered inwardly.

Yuan took a deep breath and sighed out loud, "The scent of Heaven's puppets being slaughtered is always pleasing, but it's not enough. There's not enough blood— not enough carnage!"

Yuan suddenly summoned the Empyrean Overlord and flew towards Lord Ji and the seven leaders.

"He's coming! Support me and let's kill him together!" Lord Ji also retrieved his weapon and approached Yuan.

The seven leaders followed him from behind.

"You think you can kill me?! Not even the Celestial Emperor could achieve such a feat, much less a few mutts like you!" Yuan laughed out loud as he confronted Lord Ji in the air.

"Celestial Emperor?! What nonsense are you mumbling about, you crazy monster!" Lord Ji shouted as his sword collided with Yuan's greatsword.

Clang!

"Ugh!"

Lord Ji gritted his teeth after feeling the impact behind Yuan's strike and was even pushed back many meters.

'What intense strength!" Lord Ji cried inwardly as he tried to recover from the attack..

Meanwhile, the seven leaders surrounded Yuan and started unleashing their techniques at him simultaneously.

Seeing this, Yuan used his wings to cover his body, leaving no gaps in his defenses. The power of seven Spirit Kings clashed with Yuan.

The attacks managed to create many holes in Yuan's wings, but these holes disappeared as quickly as they appeared, and the person himself was not hurt in the slightest.

"Impossible! How can he remain unharmed after eating all seven of our attacks?! What kind of technique is he using?!" Patriarch Gu exclaimed in a shocked voice.

"We don't have the time to think about it! Let's keep attacking him! I doubt he will be able to use that power for long!" The leader of the Xian Family, Patriarch Xian, shouted.

"Mongrels that can't tell the difference between Heaven and Earth, allow me to show you what happens when you point your weapons at me!"

Yuan suddenly gathered an immense amount of killing intent that condensed into a huge blade in the sky.

Lord Ji and the seven leaders were petrified on the spot from fear after witnessing the blade of killing intent in the sky.

"Asura's Blade of Execution." Yuan mumbled in a low voice as he gestured for the blade to fall towards Lord Ji and the seven leaders.

Xiao Hua momentarily stopped fighting when she noticed the blade in the sky.

'That technique! How does Brother Yuan know Xiao Hua's family technique?!' she cried inwardly.

Lord Ji and the seven leaders wanted to run away from the attack, but the pressure coming from the blade prevented them from going anywhere, forcing them to fight it head-on.

"Use all of your life-saving treasures!" Lord Ji roared in a desperate voice.

All of them immediately retrieved all of their life-saving treasures without daring to hold anything back, as their lives depended on whether they could defend this one strike from Yuan.

Over fifty kinds of life-saving treasures stood before Yuan and the others.

The Asura's Blade of Execution collided with the life-saving treasures a moment later, and it instantly shattered over half of them.

As for the rest of the life-saving treasures, they did not last long either, and the blade continued to fall.

Lord Ji and the others even used their blood essence to enhance the life-saving treasures, which would shorten their lifespan and damage their

cultivation even if they survived the attack. However, they were desperate and did not want to die.

"Yuan! Let's talk this through! We'll give up on trying to kill you! Have mercy!" Lord Ji eventually tossed aside his pride and pleaded for mercy.

The seven leaders also begged for Yuan to spare their lives.

However, Yuan's face remained nonchalant, and he spoke in a calm voice, "There is only one fate for those who dare block my path— death!"

AN: Starting now and until the end of the month, I will be giving bonus chapters for super gifts. Up to 3 bonus chapters will be released every day not including the 2 daily chapters. Also, check out Magic System in a Parallel World while you're waiting for a new chapter. It has almost 80,000 words.

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Chapter 1006 - Asura's Blade of Execution

Chapter 1006 - Asura's Blade of Execution

"There is only one fate for those who dare block my path— death!"

Yuan's words reverberate in Lord Ji's and the leaders' heads, putting them in a daze for a split second.

However, this split second was more than enough to disturb their concentration and break their defenses.

"THE HEAVENS WILL NEVER FORGIVE YOU FOR THIS, YUAN!"
Lord Ji screamed at the top of his lungs as the Asura's Blade of Execution consumed their bodies, killing them instantly.

Yuan wiped the sweat from his face after deactivating Asura's Blade of Execution. The technique required so much energy that it nearly exhausted all of his spiritual energy.

"The Heavens will never forgive me? The Heavens should be the one begging for forgiveness!"

He closed his eyes and began recovering his spiritual energy while hovering in midair.

When the army saw this, they saw this as a chance to avenge their leaders and kill Yuan while he was weak.

And since there were so many people there, Xiao Hua and the others could not hold them all back from reaching Yuan.

However, their help wasn't necessary because Yuan still had more than enough energy to deal with the leftovers of the Ji Family and the Seven Legacy Families.

Without opening his eyes or moving his body, Yuan used the Starry Abyss to kill anyone that dared to approach him.

Eventually, the rest of the army started fleeing from the battle.

With their leaders dead and without having anyone strong enough to deal with Yuan's servants, much less Yuan himself, it was basically a suicide mission with no chance of winning, so the people did what was natural—abandon the fight and run away.

"Where do you ants think you're going?! There is nowhere for you to run! The Young Master has ordered us to leave none alive! All of you insignificant ants that dared to point their weapons at my Young Master will perish here today!" Feng Yuxiang exclaimed as she released the strongest technique that she could muster with her current strength.

"Phoenix Flames Burning Heavens Art!"

Feng Yuxiang summoned her fiery wings, and flames started appearing in the sky above her, almost as though the heavens were on fire.

"Burn them all!" Feng Yuxiang flicked her sleeves, causing the sea of flames in the sky to rain down countless fiery projectiles that took the shape of a feather.

"Aaaaah!"

In mere seconds, tens of thousands of cultivators fell to Feng Yuxiang's attack.

Not wanting to lose to Feng Yuxiang, Xiao Hua started releasing Heaven Splitting Sword Strikes with every swing, changing the landscape there within moments.

When Lan Yingying saw their awespiring performance, she felt a rush of adrenaline coursing through her body and her heart throbbing with excitement.

The three servants felt as though something had ignited within their hearts after Yuan gave them their first order to fight for him, so they wanted to perform to the best of their abilities.

Although it felt like a long time had passed, in reality, only a few minutes have passed since the fight began.

The battlefield eventually became quiet, and Xiao Hua and the others returned to Yuan's side, their mission finished.

"Young Master, we have eradicated everyone from the Seven Legacy Families and the Ji Family. What are your orders now?" Feng Yuxiang said to him with a satisfied look on her face.

Yuan looked at the destruction that they had caused and spoke, "We have done something irreversible today. We might kill even more people in the future, soaking our bodies in blood. I won't blame you even if you wish to leave my side now."

"Even if you order me to kill everyone in the Nine Heavens, I would not hesitate to stain my hands for you, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Xiao Hua too!" Xiao Hua also said.

Lan Yingying silently nodded her head.

Yuan smiled when he saw the resolve in their eyes, and he spoke in a calm voice, "I'm really fortunate to have companions like you by my side."

Sometime later, Yuan's appearance returned to normal, and the Evil God's presence could no longer be felt.

"Let's gather all of the treasures here before we leave. It would be a waste to leave them here." He said to them a moment later.

They proceeded to gather all of the spatial rings and storage pouches from the battlefield.

"Young Master, I have been wanting to ask you this for a while now, but how many reincarnations have you experienced? And do you have memories from all of your past life?" Feng Yuxiang asked him as they looted the corpses.

"I don't know. I am only aware of four at this moment, and I don't have all of their memories. I have recently assimilated the Divine Paragon's memories, but I can only absorb so much at a time, so it will be a while before I fully regain all of the Divine Paragon's memories, and until I do that, I cannot touch the others' memories. Though, they sometimes leak out, just like a few minutes ago." He explained to them.

"Who was responsible for the event just now?" Feng Yuxiang asked him.

"He calls himself the Evil God. He seems to be an infamous killer that has killed countless people in the past, but I think there is more to it."

"Evil God, huh? The name sounds familiar, but I cannot remember where I heard it from." Feng Yuxiang said with a pondering face.

Xiao Hua then spoke, "Brother Yuan... That technique you used just now... Is it also because of the Evil God?"

He nodded. "That's right. Asura's Blade of Execution, huh? It's the strongest technique I have seen thus far. It must be at least an Ancient-rank technique."

"It's a Mythic-rank technique from Xiao Hua's family..." She revealed to him the origin of the technique.

"What? Really?" Yuan looked at her with wide eyes.

"So the Evil God is somehow connected with your family? How surprising..." Yuan mumbled.

"But Xiao Hua doesn't know any Evil God." She shook head.

"It's fine. We don't need to know everything right away. We will find the answers eventually."

Xiao Hua nodded.

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Chapter 1007 - Shocking the Spirit Heaven

Chapter 1007 - Shocking the Spirit Heaven

After Meixiu and the others entered the Stairway to Heaven, they appeared in the spectators' room.

"Where are we? This is the Stairway to Heaven?" Li Jinxi looked around with a curious gaze.

"This is just the spectators' room. We'll be watching Yuan participate in the trials from here. This way we can't disturb him." Chu Liuxiang explained.

"I see..."

The three of them proceeded to wait in silence.

Ten minutes passed, but it felt more like an hour to the three ladies that were anxiously waiting for Yuan to enter the Stairway to Heaven.

"How long has it been since we entered the Stairway to Heaven? It's taking too long! Did something happen to him out there?" Chu Liuxiang was the first to talk about it.

"With Feng Feng and the others with him, it will be fine." Meixiu calmly said.

"Are they really that powerful? I have never seen them fight before though." Chu Liuxiang said.

"I haven't either, but the feeling I get from them is more powerful than anyone I have met in Cultivation Online."

Meanwhile, Yuan and the others finally finished looting all of the corpses after much effort.

"How much do you think we'll get out of this?" Yuan asked after putting away the treasures.

"Honestly, you would've gotten more money from the life-saving treasures, but they were all destroyed." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Well, there's nothing I can do about that now." Yuan shrugged.

"Let's enter the Stairway to Heaven now. I don't want the others to worry since it's been a while."

He went to knock on the door shortly after.

Once the Stairway to Heaven opened, Yuan walked into the void.

Feng Yuxiang and the other two were teleported to the spectators' room after they entered.

"Welcome back, Master." A small figure approached Yuan shortly after he appeared inside the Stairway to Heaven.

"Thank you for opening the doors, Tian'er. To be honest, I wasn't confident that you would do it, but I had to try." Yuan said.

"You are the true Master of the Stairway to Heaven. The others are just fakes." She said.

"Anyways, do you mind if I take some time to recover my energy before we start? I'm a little exhausted right now."

Tian'er nodded, "Take as long as you need, Master. The trials will not officially start until you walk those stairs."

"Thank you."

Yuan took a seat right on the spot and began cultivating.

Tian'er sat before him and actually helped him recover his energy by guiding the spiritual energy within the Stairway to Heaven, making it much easier for him to absorb.

'Evil God... Why did you feel so much rage when you saw that golden medallion? What did it mean to you?' Yuan wondered to himself as he cultivated.

Meanwhile, outside the Stairway to Heaven, news of the battle that had taken place there began spreading throughout the entire Spirit Heaven like a massive wildfire.

The sheer destruction and damage the place had to endure shocked everyone in that realm. However, almost nobody in Spirit Heaven knew what had occurred there.

The only people that knew of the situation were those in the Seven Legacy Families and the Ji Family that stayed behind and did not participate in the battle, so not even the Seven— now Six Spiritual Academies knew the full situation.

When news of the battle reached the ears of those within the Seven Legacy Families and the Ji Family, they were all shocked and became filled with despair, which was only ordinary, as their leaders and most senior members had all perished in a single day!

Such devastation was unprecedented for all of these families!

Besides a few elders and the younger generation, pretty much the rest of their families were gone. Their numbers had diminished so much that they would no longer be considered a Legacy Family.

"Contact our families in the upper heavens! We cannot let that criminal escape! Since he's ascending through the Stairway to Heaven, they can set

up an ambush outside!"

The Seven Legacy Families wasted no time contacting their families in the upper heavens, letting them know of the situation.

"What?! A single person had defeated our Seven Legacy Families and the Ji Family?! How is that even possible?!" The families in the upper heavens doubted this information because it sounded utterly ridiculous and impossible.

"We're not sure if he was working alone or had help, but it's true that everyone who had gone to kill him is dead!"

"That's preposterous! What in heavens' name happened down there?!" The upper families demanded an explanation.

"The Ji Family had ordered our Seven Legacy Families to bring out all of our forces after someone had been judged 'black' by Heaven's Judgment!"

"You fool! Why did you agree to help him?! The Seven Legacy Families may have some connections to the Ji Family, but we're not their soldiers!"

"The leaders thought it was going to be easy since they were only going to kill a single Spirit Lord, and they didn't want to lose face. However, it seems like everyone has underestimated this Spirit Lord, who has unfathomable prowess!"

"What about Lord Ji and the Ji Family?"

"Lord Ji was also killed in action! However, we don't know how their family is reacting to the news."

"I think I can imagine how they're reacting..."

The leaders of the Seven Legacy Families from the upper heavens sighed.

"Where is this person that dared to slaughter people from our family? Tell me everything about him!"

The families from Spirit Heaven proceeded to tell them everything they knew about Yuan and that he had entered the Stairway to Heaven to ascend.

"I understand. Even if he manages to ascend, we will all be waiting for him outside the Stairway to Heaven. The Third Heaven will be his last stop!"

Meanwhile, at the Ji Family, a small group of individuals gathered in the meeting room, all of them showing signs of grief, as they'd just received news about the result of the battle.

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Chapter 1008 - Preparing Their Ambush

Chapter 1008 - Preparing Their Ambush

Inside the meeting room, one of the people there suddenly spoke after a long moment of silence in the room, "Is it true that my father is dead?"

"Yes, it's true. His life tablet is destroyed, and news of what happened at the Stairway to Heaven has already spread throughout the entire realm; it will only be a matter of time before the people in the upper heavens learn of the massacre."

"Have we notified our family in Third Heaven yet?"

"No, not yet."

"Then what the fuck are we doing here?! We need to notify them as soon as possible! We also need to have someone watching the Stairway to Heaven just in case he fails and stays down here for a little longer!"

"If this Yuan is talented enough to slaughter the Seven Legacy Families and our Ji Family while we're working together, there's no way that he wouldn't be able to ascend the Stairway to Heaven."

"I'm going to notify the family in Third Heaven! Time is of the essence right now! We cannot allow this criminal who has been sentenced by the Heavens to get away with his crimes!"

The direct descendant of Lord Ji left the room shortly after while everyone else remained in the meeting room to discuss their future.

"Now that the majority of our forces along with Lord Ji are dead, our family has practically become a chicken on the chopping board waiting to be slaughtered by our enemies. The moment our enemies learn the truth— that our family is defenseless, they will definitely attack us and try to replace us."

"This is a disaster not just for us. Even those in the upper heavens will be affected by this mess."

"What can we do? Go into hiding? How many years will it take before we can regain enough strength to manage this realm again? The Spirit Heavens will be destroyed by the wars that will soon plague this land before then!"

"We cannot do this alone. We've sustained too much damage to survive by ourselves now."

"Then we can only request for reinforcements and assistance from our family in the upper heavens for the time being."

Meanwhile, the Six Spiritual Academies were also having a meeting of their own to talk about the recent events.

"I don't want to make any speculations, but there is only one person that I can think of who could possibly make such a scene..." Sect Master Xiahou sighed.

"Are you talking about Yuan? That was my first thought as well. He also slaughtered the Gu Family and the Universal Music Academy." Sect Master Li said.

"According to our investigation, the corpses there belonged to the Seven Legacy Families and the Ji Family..."

"Besides them, who else could possibly amass such a massive army?"

"But why would they attack Yuan? Do you think it has anything to do with what happened at the Spirit Healing Academy?"

"It's possible, but we won't know for sure until we speak with them."

"Will they even tell us about it? I doubt they would want to talk about such a massive loss..."

"They have to— if they want our support. I highly doubt they will be able to defend themselves after losing so many people. Their families are practically crippled right now." Sect Master Li said.

"And when a family as prosperous as the Seven Legacy Families and the Ji Family suddenly become this weak, it's inevitable that they become the target of pretty much every power out there..." Bai Enjue sighed.

"We should also prepare ourselves for some visitors from the upper heaven. I doubt they will stay silent after something like this happened. They will most likely come down here to assist their own families."

Just like the Sect Masters had anticipated, the Seven Legacy Families and the Ji Family in the Third Heaven immediately started preparing to send experts to ambush Yuan at the Stairway to Heaven after learning of the situation.

Furthermore, each family prepared a couple of Spirit Kings to send to Spirit Heaven to protect them while they recovered. Even though it will cost them an astronomical amount of resources to send so many experts, they couldn't allow their families in the Spirit Heaven to perish, not to mention that their techniques and secrets could be stolen by outsiders.

The residents in Third Heaven were greatly alarmed when the Seven Legacy Families and the Ji Family suddenly gathered a massive army outside the Stairway to Heaven.

When they eventually learned of the situation in the Spirit Heaven, they understood why such drastic measures were being taken, and the entire world held their breath while they waited for Yuan to come out of the Stairway to Heaven, where he would take his last breaths.

Meanwhile, inside the Stairway to Heaven, Yuan opened his eyes after recovering from his exhaustion.

"Thank you, Tian'er. I feel even better than normal for some reason." Yuan said to her afterward.

"The spiritual energy inside the Stairway to Heaven is naturally pure, so you will gain more energy from it," she explained.

"I am going to climb the Stairway to Heaven now." Yuan said a moment later.

After approaching the staircase, he started climbing it, slowly ascending towards the next realm.

Even though it may not seem like it, every step Yuan took inside the Stairway to Heaven was akin to traveling hundreds of thousands of miles in reality.

Sometime later, Yuan arrived at the first trial.

"For the first trial, you must defend the city and survive for 24 hours. If the casualties in the city surpass 60 percent, you will fail the trial." Tian'er explained to him.

"A city-defending trial, huh? It's the complete opposite of the previous trial, where I had to kill the City Lord." Yuan smiled.

A moment later, his scenery began to change.

Once he could see clearly again, Yuan found himself inside the peak of a pagoda, and to his surprise, this was the exact same place that he'd fought the City Lord during the first trial in the past!

"Since I am protecting the city and I am in this place... Does this make me the City Lord now?" he wondered out loud.

Chapter 1009 - City Lord

Chapter 1009 - City Lord

[You have started your first trial in the Stairway to Heaven]

[You have to survive 24 hours and protect the city from outside forces]

[Finish the trial with less than 10 percent casualties in the city to receive a reward]

Yuan walked to the window and looked outside.

The city was quite massive, but it was not so big that he couldn't see the borders from his location. In fact, he could see the entire city up there.

'I don't see anyone attacking just yet...' Yuan thought to himself as he surveyed the city's surroundings.

"City Lord!"

A voice suddenly called for him.

He turned to look at the door, where a middle-aged man with a cultivation of a peak Spirit King stood.

"What's the matter?"

"We have received a report from our scouts that there is an army of 10,000 approaching the direction of our city from the north, their intentions unknown. They have over 9,000 Spirit Lords and 1,000 Spirit Kings. With such forces, I doubt they're coming here to have tea. What are your orders, City Lord?" The man reported.

Yuan's jaw almost dropped to the ground after hearing the report.

'Over 1,000 Spirit Kings?! The difficulty has ramped up so much compared to the last trial!' He cried inwardly.

He wasn't confident that he would be able to defeat such a powerful army even at his current state.

Then he realized something.

"What's the condition of our army looking like?" He asked the middle-aged man, who was wearing military armor.

"We have 1,000 Spirit Lords and 500 Spirit Kings ready to be deployed at this moment," said the middle-aged man.

'That's slightly above 10 percent of their total forces... This is going to be rough, especially if we wait for them to come. If I want that special reward, I will have to make sure that they don't get close to the city. In order for this to happen... I will have to go to them.'

After pondering for some time and coming up with a conclusion, Yuan turned to the middle-aged man and spoke, "How far away are these people?"

"They're about two hours away."

Yuan nodded and said, "Bring half of our forces with me. We're going to intercept them before they can get close to our city. As for the other half, leave them here just in case they have reinforcements."

"As you command, City Lord."

Half an hour later, Yuan and 750 soldiers left the city and made their way towards the north.

Sometime later, once they could see the enemy with their eyes, Yuan stopped and said, "Wait for my order."

"Yes!" [*The most uptodate novels are published on Freewebnovel.com*]

Yuan summoned the Empyrean Overlord and took a deep breath before he started gathering spiritual energy.

'There's only one way for us to defeat them... Taking them by surprise.'

When the enemy noticed Yuan and his small army, they stopped for a moment before resuming their movements. In their eyes, there was no way that an army of that size could possibly defeat their army with 10,000 experts.

"Keep moving! They're probably just here to speak with us! We will pretend to be peaceful, but once we're close enough, we're going to kill all of them!" The general leading that armor commanded.

"Yes!"

However, the closer they got to Yuan's army, the more they felt uneasy for some reason.

"General, I think there is something wrong here."

Once they were close enough to see Yuan's face, they were surprised.

"General! That's the City Lord! What's he doing out here?!"

"I can see that! But this is great. If we can kill him here, his city will be wide open for us to conquer." The general laughed as they continued to approach Yuan.

However, once they got close enough, Yuan suddenly released the Heavenly Sword Strike with his full power.

A massive beam of sword light flew towards the army that was too close to dodge properly, instantly killing 70 percent of the people there.

The soldiers behind Yuan were shocked speechless after witnessing the scene.

"Attack them now! I will join you guys after I recover some spiritual energy!" He said to them.

"Yes!"

The soldiers snapped out of their daze and flew towards the opposing army.

Thanks to Yuan's Heaven Splitting Sword Strike, the opposing army was in dismay, and they were too dazed to fight properly, allowing Yuan's small army to dominate them.

Yuan joined the battle shortly after, quickly killing off everyone there.

"T-That was amazing, City Lord! You took out more than half of their army with a single technique!"

"As expected of the City Lord, who is known as the God of War!"

His soldiers praised him nonstop after the battle.

"How many casualties were there?" Yuan asked them.

"We have lost several soldiers— 3 Spirit Lord and 1 Spirit King. However, this little amount of casualties is like a miracle considering the size of our enemy's army."

"Let's return to the city for now. Make sure you reward the families of those that had fallen in battle today." Yuan said to them.

"Yes!"

After returning to the city, Yuan stared at the throne on the peak of the pagoda with a pondering face.

'That man... He called me the God of War. Who is that? Tian Yang? Or is he another incarnation?' He wondered.

After pondering for a moment, he decided to forget about it for now and sat down to cultivate.

'I still have 20 hours left. I doubt this trial will end just like that.'

Just as he'd predicted, about four hours later, the middle-aged man returned with more news.

"City Lord! I have just received a report that there is another army! They are coming from the west, and they have 20,000 soldiers!"

'20,000 soldiers? That's doubled compared to the last army!' Yuan cried inwardly.

At this rate, he will need another massive area of effect technique besides the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike to deal with them.

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Chapter 1010 - City of Xian

Chapter 1010 - City of Xian

'Hmm? Wait a second... I learned how to do arrays when I was inside the Stairway to Heaven. Maybe I can learn some new techniques while I am the lord of this city!' Yuan mumbled to himself as he got this genius idea.

As the City Lord, surely, he should have some decent techniques stored away.

Unfortunately, he did not have the time to look for these techniques, as there was an army heading towards his city.

"Let's go. We're going to do the same thing we did for the last intruder, but we're going to bring more soldiers this time."

"Yes!"

The general left to gather the soldiers.

Sometime later, they left the city and started flying towards the direction of the intruders.

Once they could see the enemies, Yuan repeated what he did to the previous intruders— surprising them with a fully powered Heaven Splitting Sword Strike that changed the landscape and instantly killed thousands of intruders.

But alas, even though he'd managed to cut the intruders' numbers by 70 percent, the intruders still outnumbered them immensely.

After taking some time to recover his spiritual energy, Yuan joined the battle with the Empyrean Overlord in his grasp and the Starry Abyss by his side.

[Ten Thousand Ghost Blades!]

He cloned the Starry Abyss ten thousand times and used them to assist the other soldiers.

The blood of his enemies and allies rained from the sky as the battle raged for many minutes.

Half an hour later, Yuan fell to his knees and started gasping for air.

Fortunately, the battle had already ended and they were victorious, so he didn't have to worry about the enemies and rested.

"Are you okay, City Lord?!" **UPDATE FROM FREEWEBNOVEL.COM.**

His soldiers approached him with worried looks on their faces when they noticed how many injuries were on his body.

Even though the intruders were all Spirit Lords and Spirit Kings, they were much stronger than the cultivators in the Nine Heavens that have the same cultivation base. Even with his Invisible Dragon Cloak, he had sustained injuries.

"I am fine. These all are superficial injuries. They will heal in an instant." Yuan said to them.

And sure enough, his regeneration ability kicked in the following moment, healing his wounds fast enough for the soldiers to witness it with their bare eyes.

'If it were not for the Invisible Dragon Cloak weakening most of the damage, that would've been very dangerous...' He sighed inwardly.

"What about you guys? Are you fine? What about the casualties?" He asked them a moment later.

"It's not good. We lost around 300 men." The general shook his head with a pained expression on his face.

'300... That's almost a third of the amount of soldiers I brought with me... This is bad. And I still have to survive for over half a day. There will definitely be another invasion or two left. If I don't do something, I just might fail the first trial!' Yuan was beginning to feel the pressure of the trials.

Compared to the last time he challenged the Stairway to Heaven, the difficulty has truly increased by leaps and bounds.

Yuan began regretting his decision to purposefully increase the difficulty of the Stairway to Heaven by letting Li Jinxi and the others follow him even though he could've simply challenged the Stairway to Heaven by himself. After all, the Stairway to Heaven opened for all of the players when he cleared it the last time.

However, it was also true that he didn't want to risk the Stairway to Heaven not opening for everyone after he cleared it.

After returning to the city, Yuan immediately started to cultivate to recover his exhausted spiritual energy.

Once he recovered enough spiritual energy, he started looking around the pagoda to see if there were any hidden techniques or treasures inside.

He started from the highest floor of the pagoda, slowly making his way down.

However, even after searching the entire pagoda, he was unable to find any secret rooms or techniques.

"Nothing, huh?" Yuan sighed as he returned to the peak of the pagoda and stared outside the city.

After staring at the city for several minutes, Yuan started getting the feeling that he has been to this place before.

'Why am I suddenly feeling nostalgic? It's not like I have been here... Actually, I have, but that was during the last trial. I barely looked at the city at that time and rushed straight to this place to challenge the City Lord, so it wouldn't make sense that I am feeling nostalgia from that time...'

After pondering for some time, Yuan could only come to one conclusion.

'This city... I have definitely been here before— in my past life.'

'The location of this trial... It's not random, is it? Perhaps this place was reconstructed with the memories of my past life? This actually makes a lot of sense...'

'If this is really the case— that this place is from my memories and I am feeling nostalgia, then I should be able to remember it if I dig deep enough like the last time...'

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ALLNOVELFULL.COM TO EXPERIENCE FASTER UPDATE SPEED.**

Sometime later, Yuan took a seat in the lotus position and closed his eyes.

Once he returned to the deepest parts of his subconsciousness, he started searching through his memories.

Although he's only accepted the Divine Paragon's memories at this moment, his other memories would occasionally leak, so he could see bits and pieces of memories from his other identities.

Many minutes later, after going through many memories, he eventually found what he was looking for.

"City of Xian..." He muttered the name of the city that he was currently residing in.

Once he found what he was looking for, Yuan opened his eyes and flew outside the window.

He flew towards the east side of the city until he landed in front of a small but clean building.

When he looked at this small building, he couldn't help but feel emotional and shed some tears, even though he didn't know why.

After taking a deep breath and calming down a little, he approached it.

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Chapter 1011 - A Familiar Voice

Chapter 1011 - A Familiar Voice

Once he was in front of the door, Yuan subconsciously opened the door and entered it, all of his movements feeling incredibly natural, almost as though he'd done the same actions for years.

"Welcome home." A familiar voice suddenly resounded from the second floor.

'Huh?' Yuan raised an eyebrow after hearing this noise. Even without needing to look into his memories, he recognized this voice very well. However, why would this voice appear in this place? That part didn't make sense at all.

Yuan ignored everything on the first floor and quickly made his way onto the second floor of the building.

There were three rooms on the second floor. Only one of these rooms had a closed door, so Yuan approached that room.

After knocking on the door, he spoke, "Is it okay if I come inside?"

"Of course. This is your room as well." The familiar voice returned again.

Yuan swallowed nervously before opening the door very slowly.

Once the door was opened wide enough, Yuan looked into the room to see a beautiful mature woman with long black hair sitting on the bed beside the window.

This woman had a sharp yet delicate face, and her clear black eyes shimmered like the sea during the summer. When her gaze landed on Yuan, his body trembled.

"M-Meixiu...?" Yuan muttered after seeing this mature woman who looked exactly like Meixiu but about 10 years older.

"What are you mumbling about, you silly? Come over here." She said to him with a gentle smile on her face.

Yuan subconsciously started approaching the bed, his eyes staring directly at her face without moving.

"What's wrong? Why are you so quiet? Did something happen?" She asked him.

"Y-Yeah... Our city was under attack..."

"What?! Is everything okay?!"

"For now. I have taken care of them, but there's a good chance that they will return."

"I see... Well, as long as we have you, there's nothing to worry about. Isn't that right, God of War, Tian Xian?"

"Y-Yes..." He nodded in a dazed manner. FREEWEBNOVEL.COM

"Tian Xian... Surnamed Tian... This is most definitely one of my past lives... So I was a City Lord and also the God of War, huh?"

"Anyways, why have you returned home? Don't tell me that you came home just to see me? Although I'm flattered and very happy, I want you to focus on defending the city and its people first."

"I came back for my techniques... I might need them to defeat our enemies. Do you remember where I put them? I forgot..." He said in a stiff voice.

This kind of excuse would've never worked in the real world, but since this is merely an illusion created by the Stairway to Heaven, he decided to test his luck.

"It seems I have underestimated our situation. For you to forget about something so important, you must be feeling overwhelmed." She sighed.

"Yes... A lot of our soldiers have died today, and even more will die at this rate. I'm afraid that I won't be able to protect this city."

"Come over here." She suddenly opened her arms, gesturing for a hug.

Yuan subconsciously lowered his body, and when he did, the woman grabbed his head and pulled it towards her chest.

Yuan could feel her soft blossoms pressing against his head, but there was something else that caught his attention when he touched this woman that resembled Meixiu.

'Her stomach... There's something off about it...' He thought to himself.

A few moments later, the woman said, "Let me show you where the techniques are stored.

After releasing him, the woman removed the blankets covering her body.

When Yuan saw this woman's body and her bulged stomach, his eyes widened with shock.

'T-This is... She's pregnant?!' Yuan cried inwardly after seeing her round stomach.

When the woman noticed Yuan staring at her stomach, she smiled and said, "It's been a while since you saw it, huh? The doctor said that I will be able to give birth in three months."

Yuan swallowed nervously after hearing her words, realizing that this is his first incarnation with a wife and a child. He always thought that he had no

family of his own, not even in his previous lives, so this was quite the eye-opener.

The woman proceeded to lead Yuan to the basement.

The basement was completely empty when they entered it, but Yuan could somehow tell that there was an invisible formation protecting this place, and it was quite powerful— so powerful that even he cannot see it.

Once they descended the staircase, the woman retrieved some kind of treasure and activated it using her spiritual energy.

A portal opened up in the middle of the room a moment later.

'What kind of hiding spot is this?! There's no way that I would've been able to find this without her help!' Yuan cried inwardly after seeing the secret entrance.

Upon entering the portal, they appeared inside a small square room that had no windows or gaps. The room was completely enclosed with no way in or out besides the portal in his basement.

Inside this enclosed room was a single bookshelf. However, on this bookshelf was a single scroll.

Yuan walked to the bookshelf and took the scroll before opening it and glancing over it.

After memorizing the contents, Yuan placed the technique back on the shelf and looked at the woman.

"Thank you. I think I have what I need to defend this city now," he said with a smile.

"That's good to hear. I would like for our child to grow up in this place, after all." She chuckled.

They left the secret room and returned to the small 2 floor house shortly after.

Yuan followed the woman back to her room. Once she was back in the bed, she said to him, "I'll see you later, dear."

"Yes... See you later."

Yuan stared at her face for another moment before leaving the place and returning to the pagoda.

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Chapter 1012 - He's Back!

Chapter 1012 - He's Back!

"M-Meixiu! Look at that! She looks just like you!" Chu Liuxiang exclaimed as she pointed to the mature woman in the spectators' room.

However, Meixiu was too stumped to even respond to her.

'S-She's pregnant? With my face? Are the heavens making fun of me? Are you trying to tell me something?' Meixiu couldn't believe her eyes.

Just the other day, her mother was pressuring her to have a baby with Yuan and now this. If this wasn't a sign from the gods, what would be?

"During the last Stairway to Heaven, there was somebody with your face." Feng Yuxiang suddenly said as she looked at Chu Liuxiang.

"I remember..." She sighed.

And she continued, "Why is the Stairway to Heaven using our faces, anyway? It seems a bit odd and random."

"I can only assume that it's trying to stir with the Young Master's emotions by including people that he cares about into the trials." Feng Yuxiang shrugged.

"But why a pregnant woman...?" Meixiu shook her head with a bittersweet smile on her face.

"But you have to admit, it looks very authentic. I wonder if that's what you will look like in ten years." Li Jinxi said.

Meanwhile, Yuan returned to the peak of the pagoda, where he tried to learn the technique inside the secret room.

However, the image of Meixiu kept on appearing inside his head, thwarting his focus on the technique.

'This technique is very profound. It should be at least Ancient-rank, but this means that it will take longer for me to comprehend, and this distraction is not helping. Hopefully, I will be able to learn it before the next invasion.'

After three hours of peace, the general of the army returned.

"City Lord! I have an emergency report! There is an army of 100,000 soldiers approaching our city from the East and the West! They will arrive in 8 hours!"

"A hundred thousand...?" Yuan could feel his heart dropping after hearing such a report.

Compared to the last invasion, this one was on a whole other level.

However, he managed to keep his composure and said, "I understand. I will call you when I am ready. Do not disturb me before then no matter what. I will be entering closed door cultivation now."

"Yes!" The general disappeared shortly after.

'Eight hours... Will I be able to do it?' He sighed inwardly.

'No... I have to do it!'

After taking a deep breath, Yuan closed his eyes and cleared his head of all unnecessary thoughts.

Once he could focus on the technique, he started reciting the scripture inside his head.

Many hours later—

"Where is the City Lord?! The intruders are less than an hour away from the city!"

The soldiers approached the general and asked.

"The City Lord is currently in closed door cultivation. He will appear when the time is right."

"Even if you say that... Our opponents this time have nearly 100 times our number... And they're attacking us from two sides. Even if he's the God of War who hasn't lost a single battle in his life, there is always a first for anything. Perhaps today is the day that the God of War experiences defeat..."

"What kind of nonsense is that?! Have faith in the God of War! How many years have we followed him?! How many times did we enter battle thinking that it was an impossible fight?! How many times has he managed to surprise us?! This time will be no different! Even if we're fighting against a million soldiers, we will be victorious and remain undefeated!"

"I really hope that will be the case..."

The soldiers there sighed.

Despite the general's words, they couldn't help but fear the worst. After all, they had to fight an army of 100,000 soldiers while only having a little over 1,000 soldiers themselves.

Half an hour later, the general received another report from the scout.

"General! The enemy will reach the city walls in 15 minutes! What are your orders?!"

The general turned to look at the tall pagoda that stood proudly in the center of the city and said, "We wait for the City Lord. We will not move until we receive his order, even if the entire city is burned to the ground."

"What?! That's outrageous!"

"If you want to fight the army by yourself, you are free to do so! However, I will wait for the City Lord!"

The soldiers there looked at each other with perplexed looks on their faces, feeling conflicted.

They wanted to trust their general and the City Lord, but by doing so, they risked letting the enemy destroy the city.

However, once they thought about it, they realized that they were doomed without the City Lord, so they had no choice but to wait.

Meanwhile, two different armies with 50,000 soldiers each quickly approached the City of Xian.

"I see the city walls! The so-called 'unconquerable city' shall be conquered by my Red Lion Army today! Ahahaha!" One of the generals laughed out loud as they got closer to the city.

Inside the City of Xian, its tiny army began panicking for real when they could see the Red Lion Army closing in.

"Is the City Lord still not here?! We're doomed!"

"Damn it! I thought I would die on a fierce battlefield! This may be fierce, but this isn't a battlefield! This is a freaking slaughterhouse!"

Unbeknownst to these soldiers and even the spectators in the spectators' room, an announcement was hovering in the sky for all players to see.

Due to how long Cultivation Online has been out, announcements these days were very rare. Although there was still a lot to be discovered in Spirit Heaven, most of the players did not have the capability to explore this vast land.

"L-Look at the announcement! He's back!" The players exclaimed in excitement when they saw the name in the announcement.

[Player Yuan has become the world's first player to have learned a Mythic-rank Skill! Congratulations!]

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Chapter 1013 - God of War's Astral Arts

Chapter 1013 - God of War's Astral Arts

"General! The enemy is right outside our city walls! They're demanding that we surrender the city!" A soldier reported to the general.

However, before he could even respond, a loud and arrogant voice resounded from outside the city, "Surrender and there won't be unnecessary bloodshed!"

"We have over a hundred thousand soldiers, all above Spirit Lord! You will not win this battle with your puny army!"

"I would also prefer for this city to be intact after we conquer it! You have half an hour to come to a decision!"

"I repeat! Surrender and we will spare your lives! The only one who has to die is the City Lord, Tian Xian!"

The place fell silent afterward. After a few moments of absolute silence, once everyone realized their situation, the entire City of Xian began panicking.

"City Lord! Save us!"

"Where is the God of War when we need him?!"

"Do you think a single person can get rid of our predicament?! Even if he's the God of War, there's no way that he would be able to defeat an army of 100,000 by himself!"

"What about his army?!"

"The army had suffered a huge loss recently after an intense battle that lasted for 30 days and nights straight! We barely have anyone left!"

"Damn it! Are we truly doomed?!"

"I have faith in the City Lord! He has never disappointed us before!"

"Open your damn eyes! This is an unwinnable battle!"

Time passed in an instant while the residents of the city panicked for 30 minutes straight.

The general outside the city spoke again, "Time is up! Thirty minutes have passed! We showed mercy, yet you ignored our generosity! Since this is how you want to play, we will play!"

"All forces— charge! Kill everyone who opposes!"

The 100,000 strong army began rushing towards the City of Xian.

However, an immense pressure suddenly enveloped the whole place, forcing the soldiers to halt their steps.

The soldiers outside the city and the residents in the city all lifted their heads to look towards the pagoda in the middle of the city, where a majestic figure with an overwhelming aura could be seen hovering in the sky, his presence demanding for everyone's submission.

"T-The City Lord! It's the City Lord! He's finally here to save us!"

"You idiot! Even if he's here, what can he do against such a powerful army?! We're still doomed!"

Meanwhile—

"Ahahaha! You have finally decided to crawl out of your rat hole, God of War!" The Red Lion Army's general laughed out loud, his laughter causing

ripples in the air.

Yuan glanced at the Red Lion Army that surrounded the city.

"Surrender yourself, God of War! If you do, we won't lay a finger on your city or the residents!"

The people in the city swallowed nervously, and they all anxiously waited for Yuan's response.

Yuan took a deep breath and spoke, "I have a slightly different proposal. Get out of my face before I kill all of you."

The residents in the city began crying after hearing Yuan's words.

"We're all dead! It's over for this city!"

"The City Lord is too arrogant! All those victories must have got into his head and made him disconnected from reality!"

"If you want to commit suicide, go do it by yourself! Don't drag the rest of us into your madness!"

The residents of the city that had been loyal to him for many years have finally lost their hope and respect. After all, a righteous and reasonable City Lord would sacrifice himself for his city without hesitation.

However, Yuan ignored the complaints coming from beneath him, as he was sure that it was the Stairway to Heaven trying to stir his emotions.

He closed his eyes and took a deep breath as he recited the technique he'd just learned inside his head.

When he opened his eyes, they glowed golden, and a subtle but visible golden aura started appearing from his body.

He summoned the Empyrean Overlord and spoke in a cold voice, "All of you will be my training puppets for today."

[God of War's Astral Arts!]

The people there watched as Yuan's golden aura started expanding at a rapid rate until it was large enough to cover the entire City of Xian.

Once it stopped growing, the aura began transforming until it resembled half a human wearing a golden armor. Furthermore, it had two massive arms that were wielding a large greatsword that resembled the Empyrean Overlord.

"What in heavens' name is that technique?!" The intruders cried out loud when they saw the giant behind Yuan, feeling as though they were ants before an elephant.

[God of War's Astral Arts]

[Rank: Mythic]

[Mastery Level: 1]

[Description: Create a powerful astral avatar that can seize stars and destroy worlds with your Soul Strength. The stronger your Soul Strength, the more powerful the astral avatar]

'I need to finish this fast. I can feel my strength being exhausted at a ridiculous rate!' Yuan cried inwardly after realizing how much energy this technique required.

He took a deep breath before swinging the Empyrean Overlord in his grasp, and the astral avatar followed his movements, sweeping the army outside the city with its massive sword.

BOOM! FREEWEBNOVEL.COM

The entire ground viciously shook, and an unimaginable crater appeared in the ground where one of the armies stood.

As for the army, they were all completely flattened with a single strike— all 50,000 of them.

When the other army saw the destruction caused by the astral avatar, their faces paled.

"S-Scatter! SCATTER!" The general leading that army roared.

But alas, the astral avatar was already in a swinging motion.

The ground shook for a second time when the first earthquake hadn't even ended yet.

After killing all 100,000 soldiers from the Red Lion Army with two mere strikes, Yuan deactivated the technique and immediately returned to the pagoda to rest, not even bothering to look at the destruction he'd caused.

The entire city was dead silent afterward, and it would remain silent for many minutes with not a single person there believing what they had just witnessed.

Chapter 1014 - Proceeding to the Second Trial

"What in heaven's name was that technique just now?! I have never seen anything remotely that powerful before!" Feng Yuxiang cried out loud after seeing Yuan decimate an entire army of 100,000 Spirit Lords and Spirit Kings with two strikes.

"I have never seen Brother Yuan use that technique before. He must have just learned it." Xiao Hua said.

"You can actually learn techniques while doing trials in the Stairway to Heaven? How come I have never heard of such a thing? And judging by the prowess of that technique, I dare say that it's at least an Ancient-rank technique if not Mythic-rank!" Feng Yuxiang was in disbelief.

If people realize that they could learn such powerful techniques inside the Stairway to Heaven for free, there would definitely be a massive uproar throughout the Nine Heavens.

Meanwhile, back at the pagoda, Yuan gave up on trying to recover his soul strength after realizing that he didn't have any cultivation techniques that recovered his soul strength.

Unlike spiritual energy, soul strength could not be restored through ordinary cultivation techniques. In order to recover soul strength faster than naturally allowed, one must know a soul cultivation technique, but these techniques are incredibly rare even in the upper heavens.

'Looks like I won't be able to use the God of War's Astral Arts until my soul strength naturally recovers. Fortunately, I can still use my other techniques

that only require spiritual energy.' He sighed inwardly.

Despite the God of War's Astral Arts' immense power and seemingly unlimited potential, it was not something he could use too often at this moment. Until he acquires a soul cultivation technique, he will have to limit its usage for life-or-death situations.

After giving up trying to restore his soul strength, Yuan looked at the amount of time he had left.

'Less than fifteen minutes left...'

Sometime later, he returned to the house with the woman who looked exactly like Meixiu.

"Is everything okay?" She asked him as she gently rubbed her round stomach.

"Yes, I have dealt with the intruders. The city is safe again." He nodded.

"That's good to hear. Now our child can grow up in the city that you have painstakingly protected and developed," she said with a beautiful smile on her face.

"Have you thought of a name for the child yet?" Yuan suddenly asked out of curiosity.

"No, not yet. I was hoping we could name her together."

"It's a girl, huh..." He smiled.

<You have defended the city for 24 hours and successfully cleared the first trial>

<You have cleared the trial with less than 10 percent casualties>

"Here you go." The woman suddenly extended her hands, offering him a glowing orb of light.

"Thank you." Yuan accepted the orb of light and absorbed it.

However, his cultivation base did not increase like the previous reward.

Instead, he could feel his soul strength becoming stronger.

[+100,000 Soul Strength]

'Wow, this reward is actually much better than I initially thought. It's definitely countless times better than just increasing my cultivation base.' Yuan thought to himself after realizing what the bonus reward was.

The City of Xian disappeared before Yuan's eyes, and he returned to the Stairway to Heaven shortly after.

"Congratulations on passing the trial, Master. Do you wish to rest? You are allowed an hour to rest." Tian'er said to him.

He nodded, "Yes, I will rest this time."

Even though his spiritual energy was full, he wanted to allow his soul strength to recover even if it's just slightly. He had a feeling that the God of War's Astral Arts was going to be crucial for his upcoming trials.

'Oh? My soul strength is recovering faster than normal out here.' Yuan quickly realized this as he sat down to monitor his recovery.

An hour later, Yuan stood up and proceeded onto the next trial.

"For the second trial, you must protect the Huang Family while they exchange their valuables in the Giant's Continent."

"Oh? Is it the same Huang Family as the previous trial? So we're going to continue where we left off, huh?" Yuan was a little excited to meet with the Huang Family again, especially Huang Xiao Li, who taught him array symbols.

The scenery began changing, and before he realized, he was standing on the ship deck while surrounded by water.

[You have started your second trial in the Stairway to Heaven]

[Protect the Huang Family as they exchange their treasures on the Giant's Continent]

[Finish the trial without any casualties in the Huang Family to receive a reward]

"Why are you standing there in a daze, Yuan?"

A familiar voice suddenly resounded, causing Yuan to turn around.

Standing behind him was a beautiful young lady with a bright smile on her face. Of course, she was Huang Xiao Li, who also resembled Chu Liuxiang.

"It's been a while, Xiao Li." He said with a gentle smile on his face.

"What are you talking about? Are you still daydreaming? You should snap out of it since we're about to land. Look over there— that's the Giant's Continent!" She pointed at the massive island in the distance.

However, Yuan wasn't paying attention to the island. Instead, he was focused on Huang Xiao Li.

'Her cultivation hasn't changed. She's still a Spirit Grandmaster. The same goes for everyone on this boat. It's almost as though I'd never left in the first place for them.' He thought the Stairway to Heaven would scale these people to his level since this was a new and more difficult trial, but that didn't seem to be the case.

Sometime later, the ship stopped moving once it reached land, and everyone onboard started to disembark.

"Yuan, are you ready? We have only 14 days to exchange our treasures and come back, or we will be stuck here for a very long time!" Huang Xiao Li said to him.

'14 days... I really hope this isn't how long the trial will take...' He sighed inwardly as he disembarked the ship with the Huang Family and the other

bodyguards.

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Chapter 1015 - Mammoth Bloodline

Chapter 1015 - Mammoth Bloodline

After disembarking from the ship, Yuan followed Huang Xiao Li and her family onto the land.

'Giant's Continent... It's not in Tian Chengyu's memories. Did this place exist before his birth or after his death?' He wondered as he followed them.

Sometime later, he asked out of curiosity, "Where are we going now?"

"We're going to the Southern Stronghold. It's where most travelers like us go to exchange treasures with giants, so it's quite popular." Huang Xiao Li said.

"I don't know much about giants. Can you tell me about them?"

"Sure!" She nodded with enthusiasm, and she continued, "Giants are humans with the Mammoth Bloodline. Their ancestors were ordinary humans that have trained a unique technique called the Great Mammoth Body Refinement that gave them immense strength and a near indestructible body, but it also increased their body size temporarily."

"Their ancestors not only reached the peak with this technique, they had even altered it so that the technique would continuously affect their bodies and never deactivate, making them giants permanently. However, because such a feat required them to alter their genes and blood, their descendants would also be born with such blood and genes in their body, making them giants at birth."

Yuan was speechless after hearing this information. The speed was too fast, and with a swoosh, Wang Xuan was pulled into the whirlpool, like a little crucian carp that had been hooked and was violently pulled out of the water.

Giants used to be humans before they altered their blood and genes with a technique? He didn't know techniques were even capable of such a feat, which was akin to creating their own bloodline and race!

Huang Xiao Li continued to speak, "The giants created their own family, and after cultivating that family for thousands of years, they moved to an uninhabited land that would soon to be known as the Giant's Continent."

"Giants nowadays are mostly isolated within the Giant's Continent, so you won't see them outside. In fact, most people live their entire life without meeting one. They're practically phoenixes and dragons."

"However, since they rarely leave the continent, they mostly rely on travelers like us to provide them with resources and treasures from the outside. It benefits us as well because there are resources and treasures that can only be found within the Giant's Continent."

"That's pretty neat, I guess." Yuan mumbled.

"Indeed. If you have any treasures you don't need, you can try to exchange or sell them to the giants."

A bittersweet smile appeared on his face after hearing her words. Even if he had plenty of treasures that he could and wanted to trade, he wouldn't actually acquire anything because he was inside the Stairway to Heaven and nothing there was real. If you dare to fish against him like this, no matter if it's a strange thing on a mobile phone or that ferocious giant fish, you'll have to pay the price.

'Although I can learn techniques in the Stairway to Heaven, that is only possible because they only need to be memorized. However, treasures don't work that way. It's impossible for me to acquire real treasures during trials.

How unfortunate.' He sighed inwardly, thinking how nice it would be if he could actually acquire something from the trial.

Suddenly, the head of the bodyguards, Dong Zhou, shouted, "We have company!"

Yuan panicked a little when he heard Dong Zhou's voice because he didn't sense anything with his divine sense that he's kept active this whole time.

However, sure enough, something appeared before them a few seconds later, and it was a massive bird that was so big that it could easily lift an entire building with one of its claws.

Seeing this massive bird that came out of thin air, Yuan prepared to attack it, but then he realized its cultivation base was in the Spirit Emperor realm.

'Spirit Emperor magical beast! This is my first time fighting an opponent of this level!' He cried inwardly.

"Yuan! It's coming!" Huang Xiao Li shouted. A fish is mocking him!

Yuan immediately snapped out of his daze and confronted this massive bird in the sky right as it tried to dive down.

"Ha!"

He enveloped the Empyrean Overlord with Sword Qi before sending it in the magical beast's way.

"Kaaaw!" The bird released a painful scream when it lost one of its claws to Yuan, who was surprised because he'd expected to kill the bird with that strike.

PAN DA N OVEL However, before he could get another strike on the bird, it turned around and flew away, leaving him speechless.

"It ran away...?" He muttered in a dumbfounded voice.

"Are you okay, Yuan?!" Huang Xiao Li approached him afterward. Then, it was noisy and motionless, instead of reviving here, it chose to disguise it.

"Yes, I am fine. But that magical beast was stronger than I anticipated."

After all, under normal circumstances, his attack just now would've killed even a Spirit Emperor with ease.

"I forgot to mention this, but giants are not the only entity on this continent with the Mammoth Bloodline. The magical beasts on this continent also have it," she said to him.

"What? How is that even possible? I thought the giants' ancestors only managed to achieve such a feat through a technique! There's no way ordinary magical beasts could possibly comprehend techniques, much less master them!"

"You're right, but the magical beasts did not acquire the Mammoth Bloodline through techniques. They acquired it through consuming the giants. I mentioned that the technique is never-ending, right? This is still true even when the giants die, so when a magical beast consumes their flesh and blood, they also acquire the power of giants."

"Heavens..." Yuan was speechless by this information.

Since the magical beasts in the Giant's Continent also had the Mammoth Bloodline coursing through their veins, they were much stronger than ordinary magical beasts from the outside. If one piece of sword energy can't solve the problem, then take a few more pieces. Wang Xuan is going to kill it.

"It seems we have underestimated the strength of this place. We're not strong enough to do our job as bodyguards, so we'll have to rely on you, Yuan." Dong Zhou approached him and said.

"Sure..." He sighed, silently wondering to himself why the Stairway to Heaven didn't make the bodyguards at least Spirit Kings so that they

wouldn't be completely useless. After all, in their current state, they were nothing but a burden to him.

"Since you're all too weak to traverse this land, why don't you just return to the ship and wait for us to return?" Yuan said to him a moment later.

"We cannot do that! Even if we're not strong enough to fight the entities on this land, we must still do our jobs as bodyguards and accompany the Huang Family even if we die in the process!" Dong Zhou exclaimed in a prideful voice.

Yuan felt like facepalming.

'If you cannot do your duties as a bodyguard, can you still be considered as one?!' He cried inwardly.

Yuan eventually stopped thinking about it since it was most likely done by the Stairway to Heaven to make things more difficult for him.

"Just so you know, I am here to protect the Huang Family, so if you get in any trouble..."

"Don't worry, we won't drag you down." Dong Zhou said with a confident smile.

"Yeah... I somehow doubt that..." He shook his head.

After walking for about half an hour without encountering any magical beasts, Huang Xiao Li pointed at the city walls in the distance and said in an excited voice, "We're almost there! I can see the Southern Stronghold!"

They quickened their moving speed after seeing the city.

However, as they got closer, Dong Zhou suddenly stopped and shouted, "We're surrounded!"

Yuan looked around, and sure enough, a pack of massive birds quickly surrounded them, and amongst these magical beasts was one with an injured claw—the same one he'd fought.

"So you ran away to call your friends, huh?" Yuan couldn't help but chuckle at its efforts.

After a quick glance, he counted 9 of these birds, and they all emitted the aura of a Spirit Emperor.

'I won't be able to fight all of them at once and protect the Huang Family at the same time with my ordinary techniques. I will have to use the God of War's Astral Arts...' He sighed inwardly, feeling a little embarrassed to use his trump card so early on in the trial.

Although he could kill these magical beasts even without the God of War's Astral Arts, he wouldn't be able to protect the Huang Family, and his priority was to keep all of them alive for the bonus reward.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan used the God of War's Astral Arts.

The Huang Family and the bodyguards were shocked speechless after witnessing the massive golden figure.

As for the birds, they started making weird noises, almost as though they were panicking.

"Die!"

Not wanting to waste his soul strength too much, Yuan immediately attacked the birds with a 360 sword swing, killing all of them at once.

However, the attack was so powerful that it created a powerful gust of wind that swept in all directions.

In fact, the Southern Stronghold thought they were under attack when they saw the golden figure that looked massive even though they were quite far away from Yuan's location.

Yuan quickly deactivated the technique after killing the magical beasts.

"A-Are you okay?" Huang Xiao Li asked him in a worried voice after seeing his poor condition.

"Yes, I am fine. That technique uses up a lot of soul strength, so I am a little tired— mentally. Give me a few minutes to recover."

"Alright." They nodded.

A few minutes later, once Yuan was feeling better, they continued their journey to the Southern Stronghold, unaware of the chaos that was occurring within the city due to Yuan's God of War's Astral Arts.

After another hour of traveling, they arrived at the entrance of the city.

'So that's a giant, huh?' Yuan was amazed when he saw the two giants guarding the entrance to the city, both of them being around 10 meters tall with a broad frame and incredible muscles that looked like they could crush an entire mountain.

'Besides their massive size, they look just like humans. I guess it's true that their ancestors were originally normal humans.' Yuan thought to himself as they approached these giants.

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AN: Chapters for CO will be longer starting June. Also, check out Magic System in a Parallel World while you wait for the next chapter! It has long chapters just like this one!

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Chapter 1016 - Serious Accusations

Chapter 1016 - Serious Accusations

As they got closer to the giants, Yuan could feel their gaze on him, and sure enough, when he looked at them, their eyes were glaring directly at him for some reason.

Yuan wanted to ignore them, but when they got close enough to the entrance of the city, the giants suddenly stepped in front of the entrance, blocking their path.

The Huang Family were quite baffled by their actions. Unlike cities outside the Giant's Continent, the Southern Stronghold did not require for them to pay any entrance fees, nor did they care about your background, so there was literally no reason why they should be blocking the entrance.

"Is there something wrong, Seniors?" Huang Chen, Huang Xiao Li's father, asked the guard in a polite tone.

The guards pointed at Yuan and asked, "Who are you? What is your purpose?"

Yuan raised an eyebrow and said in a calm voice, "I am Yuan, and I am their bodyguard."

The guards turned to look at Huang Chen for confirmation.

"That's right. He's a bodyguard that I hired to protect my family. It was because of him that we— and everyone else on the ship were able to survive a Flying Leviathan and arrive at the Giant's Continent safely." Huang Chen nodded.

"You defeated a Flying Leviathan?" The guards appeared to be surprised after learning about his feats.

The two of them exchanged looks with each other for a moment before stepping out of the way.

"Thank you, Seniors." Huang Chen bowed to them before they started moving again, entering the Southern Stronghold shortly after.

"What was that about?" Yuan asked them.

"I don't know, but giants respect and prioritize one's strength above all else." Huang Chen shook his head.

Once they entered the city, Yuan was dumbfounded by the scenery inside.

All of the buildings in this place were massive and about 10 times larger than the buildings that he was used to seeing, not to mention the amount of giants walking around the city, making him feel really tiny in this place, just like an ant.

Furthermore, he also noticed that the giants in this place really varied in terms of their size. Some of them were only as tall as 4 meters while there were giants as tall as 15 meters.

"You're probably wondering about their sizes, right?" Huang Xiao Li suddenly said to him.

"You're right. I thought all giants were as big as the guards outside, but that doesn't seem to be the case." He nodded.

"It depends on the strength of their Mammoth Bloodline. The purer and stronger their bloodline, the bigger they will turn out to be. In the Giant's Continent, a giant's size is akin to a cultivator's innate talent, so those with a smaller body are considered trash while those with a large body are considered geniuses," she explained.

"If you're surprised now, just wait until you see giants that are as big as a mountain."

Yuan eyes widened.

"As big as a mountain? No wonder why they refuse to leave the Giant's Continent. They won't be able to do anything outside with such huge bodies."

Sometime later, they went to a hotel to settle down. Although most of the hotels there were built specifically for giants, there were also hotels specifically built for humans like them.

Once inside the hotel, Huang Chen gathered everyone there and said, "We will rest today, but starting tomorrow, I will be looking to exchange our treasures with the giants. I will leave two of you here to guard my family while the rest will follow me."

Yuan frowned upon hearing his words.

'I won't be able to protect all of them if we split into two groups. Perhaps I should convince them to go together, but they have a child...' He glanced at the seven-year-old boy beside his mother.

'Maybe it would actually be safer to leave him and the mother here...' He sighed inwardly.

With so many giants walking outside, things could get ugly really fast if they take such a small child outside. After all, he was so tiny compared to some of the giants that they could easily step on him by accident and not even realize it.

Of course, this also applied to the mother, who had the lowest cultivation base besides the child who was still too young to cultivate.

However, there was another issue—the bodyguards.

He wasn't confident in their abilities at all. In fact, they will probably be useless since this trial was countless times more difficult than the last trial, yet their strength remained the same as the last trial. In other words, they were nothing more than burdens.

'Furthermore, these guys...' Yuan narrowed his eyes at the bodyguards, his thoughts unknown.

After Huang Chen finished everything he had to say, Yuan approached Huang Xiao Li with a smile and said to her in a low voice, "Excuse me, Xiao Li. Do you mind if I borrow some of your time? I would like to speak to you in private."

"Sure..." She nodded in a dazed manner, feeling a little nervous about the aura around him.

"Follow me."

Yuan nodded and followed her into another room. Once she locked the door, she asked him, "So what do you want to talk about? Did something happen? You seem a little more serious than usual..."

"Yes... It's about—" Yuan proceeded to tell her what's been on his mind.

Huang Xiao Li's eyes widened more and more with shock as she listened to his words.

"A-Are you sure about that?! Those are some serious accusations!" She exclaimed in a low voice.

He nodded with a serious frown, "I didn't notice it before because I was still inexperienced. However, I am certain about my claims. I don't mind dealing with it right now, but I can tell that you're doubtful, so I am going to prove it to you first."

"How are you going to do that?"

Yuan proceeded to tell her about his plans. All **NOVEL** full.com

"Seriously...? You want me to..."

"Do you trust me?" Yuan suddenly asked her with a serious expression.

"I risked my life to defend the ship and your Huang Family. I wouldn't do anything to hurt you or your family—I promise."

"O-Of course I trust you!" Huang Xiao Li's face quickly flushed with redness when she recalled what she tried to do with him right before the Flying Leviathan's attack.

A moment later, she took a deep breath and nodded with a serious expression, "Alright, let's do it."

"Thank you. You won't regret it, I promise." Yuan smiled.

The two of them left the room after talking for several more minutes.

"Is everything okay, Yuan?" Huang Chen approached him shortly after he left the room with Huang Xiao Li.

"Father, I need to speak with you. Mother, you too." Huang Xiao Li suddenly said to them.

Huang Chen looked at them with raised eyebrows, but he didn't ask any questions and followed Huang Xiao Li to another room.

Once the Huang Family was gone, the other guards approached Yuan and asked him, "What happened?"

"Is everything okay? The young lady looked very annoyed."

"I hope you didn't try to confess your love for her just now. You're just a bodyguard. Know your place." The female bodyguard said to him with a mocking gaze.

Yuan didn't take her insults to heart and even chuckled at it, "Don't worry, it's nothing like that. However, it's true that something did happen."

The guards swallowed nervously as they waited for him to speak.

"I would tell you, but I think it would be for the best if the Huang Family told you. It's their business, after all." He shrugged, not willingly to tell

them anything.

"Come on! Don't be like that!" Qin Kai, who was the bulky bodyguard that guarded the Huang Family's room with him while they were still sailing, said.

"I don't want to lose my job, so I will have to refrain from it."

"Whatever. Keep your stupid little secret." The other bodyguards shook their heads and stopped bothering him.

Sometime later, the Huang Family finished their little meeting and came out of the room, but Huang Chen and his wife looked really upset for some reason.

This made the guards really nervous, and they all wondered inwardly about the issue.

Huang Chen gathered the bodyguards again and said, "There will be some changes in our plans. I will start exchanging my treasures today, so I want two people to follow me."

He looked at Yuan and his head bodyguard Dong Zhou.

"Yuan and Dong Zhou, you'll be coming with me. Xiao Li, you'll also come with me. The rest of you will stay behind to protect my wife and son. Do not let anyone besides us enter this place no matter what."

"Yes!" They all said.

Before they left, Huang Chen said to his wife in a low voice, "Since we have too many treasures, I will leave half of it with you. If anything happens to us, I want you to take the treasures and go home."

"Don't say something so ominous. As long as you have Yuan with you, he'll keep you safe." She said with a smile.

Yuan left the hotel with his group shortly after.

Once they were outside, Dong Zhou couldn't help but ask, "Sorry if I am being noisy, but what was that about?"

"I will tell you about it in a bit." Huang Chen said.

Dong Zhou has never seen Huang Chen so serious before, making him worried as well.

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Chapter 1017 - The Gold and Money Bandits

Chapter 1017 - The Gold and Money Bandits

Shortly after Yuan's group left to exchange treasures, the bodyguards that had remained at the hotel watched from the windows as Yuan and the others disappeared from the scene.

"Those nuisances have finally left." The female bodyguard sneered.

"Should we do it now? This is the best time. That little bastard with too much power for someone at his age and level is gone, as well as the array master and even Huang Chen and his daughter. Nobody here can stop us now," said one of the male bodyguards.

"I don't know... This seems a little too easy... Not to mention whatever just happened. Something about all of this doesn't sit right with me," said a different bodyguard.

"Who cares! We can kill the woman and the kid and rob them of all of their treasures long before they will be able to do anything about it!" The female bodyguard showed a grim smile on her face.

"I say we should do it as well. I doubt there will be another chance like this."

"What about that other bodyguard? He might cause us some trouble."

"I can handle him," said the female bodyguard with a suggestive expression on her face.

In the end, these bodyguards decided to finally execute their plan by robbing the Huang Family.

These three bodyguards actually knew each other before they got hired by the Huang Family, as they all belonged to a renowned gang that was infamous for their vicious deeds and brutal nature.

The Gold and Money Bandits— they were a group of lawless cultivators that would dare to rob and kill even mortals, something only evil cultivators would do.

In fact, there were even more of these bandits at the bodyguard recruitment, but most of them had been disqualified and only these three had managed to pass.

They had planned on robbing the Huang Family when they were still at sea, but Yuan did not give them any chance, and when they saw how powerful he actually was, they decided to delay their plans until they could find an opportunity to rob the Huang Family.

Now that they have finally encountered that opportunity, they were enticed to finally execute their plans and rob the Huang Family.

Meanwhile, a few minutes after they left the hotel, Huang Chen revealed the whole situation to Dong Zhou, who had been kept in the dark until now.

"What?! Those bodyguards harbor ill intentions?! Are you sure this is accurate information?!" Dong Zhou doubted this information, mostly because he didn't want to believe that he had accidentally recruited bandits to be their bodyguards, as he could be held responsible for this blunder.

"It's true. I wasn't certain at first, but after watching them for some time, I can say with certainty that they are bandits. Their bodies reeked of blood and their eyes are filled with greed. Do you remember when we were attacked in the ship? I believe they were working together since they all gave off the same aura."

P AND A N OVEL "Yuan wouldn't lie to us! He risked his life fighting the Flying Leviathan, too!" Huang Xiao Li backed him up.

Dong Zhou frowned and said, "If what you say is true, then isn't it incredibly dangerous and reckless to leave the Madam and the Young Master alone with them?! We're basically giving them to those bastards on a silver platter!"

"If we didn't leave, they would not act. I also wanted to prove to all of you that they are not what they seem. Don't worry, I won't let them touch even a hair on the Huang Family."

"What the hell can you do when you're here with us?! This is madness!" Dong Zhou exclaimed.

"I trust him." Huang Chen suddenly said.

"A-Are you serious, Master Huang? What if he's only doing this to mislead us? What if he's actually working with those bandits?!"

Yuan smiled after hearing his words and said in a calm voice, "Do you really think I need to make such an elaborate plan just to rob the Huang Family? Have you not seen what I am capable of? If I want to rob you guys, I wouldn't need to pretend to be a bodyguard and wait until you lower your guard, much less come all the way out here and risk my life fighting the Flying Leviathan. If I truly wanted to rob you guys, I would've done so before we boarded the ship, and none of you would've be able to stop me."

Dong Zhou swallowed nervously when he called how Yuan had killed multiple Spirit Emperors with a single strike.

"Sorry... I was just talking out of my ass just now..." Dong Zhou sighed out loud.

Yuan suddenly turned around and looked at the direction of the hotel.

"Let's return. They're finally moving," he said to them.

Back at the hotel, the female bandit approached Qin Kai and started flirting with him.

"I have been wanting to speak with you for a while now, but I didn't get any chance. You know, I love men with muscles, and when I first saw you, I knew right away that I wanted you. You're the reason I even decided to become a bodyguard for the Huang Family."

Qin Kai swallowed nervously after hearing her words.

"Seriously?"

The female bandit was actually quite attractive, and Qin Kai had little to no experience when it comes to women, making him an easy target.

"Let's go elsewhere to talk, shall we?" She winked at him.

"S-Sure..." Qin Kai followed her to another room.panda novel

Once the other two bandits saw this, they smiled and turned their focus to the room with the mother and wife.

"Let's go."

The two of them quietly approached the room.

Once they were close enough, one of them tried to open the door in a sneaky manner.

When the bandit couldn't feel any resistance from the door, the smile on his face widened.

"Ready?"

"Of course."

The bandit immediately opened the door, and the two of them entered the room before closing it again.

"W-What are you two doing in here?! I don't remember calling either of you!" The mother said to them with a frown on her face.

"Don't worry, we'll leave you alone once we take all of your treasures and kill you," said one of the bandits.

"You what?!"

"The Gold and Money Bandits, have you heard of us?"

"The mother's eyes widened with shock after hearing that name.

"I see... So you became our bodyguards just to steal from us, huh. We should've been more diligent when recruiting bodyguards, but we were in a rush."

"Then you can only blame yourself."

"Ah, I would love to enjoy my time with you before killing you, but we're short on time, so I am just going to kill you."

They retrieved their weapons.

However, the mother managed to calm down, and she even smiled, "What a pity."

"A pity indeed."

One of the bandits suddenly rushed forward while swinging his dagger, but before he could reach the mother, he felt a burst of pain in his chest, forcing him to look down.

"What the fuck...?" He muttered in a dumbfounded voice when he saw that a hole had mysteriously appeared in his chest.

Thud.

The bandit fell to the floor and died before he could even realize what had happened to him.

The other bandit stood there with a dazed look on his face as his eyes stared at his companion's lifeless body on the floor. Despite seeing everything that had just happened, he still couldn't comprehend the situation.

The door behind him suddenly opened, and a figure calmly walked into the room.

"Are you okay? Madam Huang?" Yuan asked her with a calm smile on his face.

"Y-You are... How in heaven's name..." The bandit was shocked when he saw Yuan standing right beside him.

"Did you really think that I wouldn't notice the way you idiots looked at the Huang Family? When you look at them, you only see money and profit, and it reminds me of a certain miserable couple." Yuan sneered in a cold voice.

"Senior Huang. Xiao Li. What do you think? Is this enough proof?" He asked them, who were standing right behind the bandit with deep frowns on their faces.

"Yes, this is more than enough proof. Thank you very much, Yuan. You have saved our family yet again." Huang Chen said.

It was at this moment the female bandit and Qin Kai came out of their room after hearing the commotion.

"W-What is happening?!" Qin Kai exclaimed with a shocked look on his face when he saw the incomprehensible situation.

As for the female bandit, she was simply speechless.

Chapter 1018 - I Will Accept Your Challenge!

Chapter 1018 - I Will Accept Your Challenge!

Huang Chen frowned when he saw the female bandit and Qin Kai.

"Where the hell have you two been?! My family was being attacked and you're screwing each other in another room?! Why did I even hire you!"

"W-What?! Attacked!? By whom?!" Qin Kai was truly puzzled, as he was not part of the Gold and Money Bandits. Furthermore, everything had happened so fast that he was still comprehending the situation.

"Why don't you take a look for yourself?" Huang Xiao Li pointed into the room with Yuan and the bandits.

Qin Kai swallowed nervously and approached the room.

His eyes widened with shock when he saw the scene inside. One of the bodyguards was dead with a hole in his chest and the other was frozen in place with a terrified expression on his face.

"What is the meaning of this?" Qin Kai asked.

"These two are bandits from the Gold and Money Bandits. They became a bodyguard just to rob the Huang Family." Yuan calmly explained the situation to him.

"The Gold and Money Bandits?!" Qin Kai immediately recognized their name. As someone who often works as a bodyguard, he has encountered

these bandits on multiple occasions, and they were all vicious people with no morals.

Murder, robbery, corruption, rape— nothing was off the table for these bandits even if mortals were involved, hence why they were so hated and so feared.

The female bandit also took a look inside the room. Her heart throbbed so fast and hard from fear that it began hurting.

'Fortunately, they didn't catch me in the act, so they don't know that I am with them just yet. But if they ask that bastard, he will surely give me away!' She calmed down slightly after realizing this, and she began plotting to kill her companion before he could speak.

However, with Yuan in the room, she didn't dare to move just yet.

"So tell me, what were the two of you doing while my family was attacked? Are you also part of the Gold and Money Bandits?" Huang Chen narrowed his eyes at Qin Kai and the female bandit.

"What?! Hell no! There's no way I am with those bastards!"

"T-That's right! We were in the other room because I wanted to make love to him! I didn't know they were bandits! I swear!" The female bandit said.

The other bandit cursed inwardly after hearing her companions' words.

'That fucking bitch! She's the whole reason we're in this mess! If she didn't make the suggestion to rob the Huang Family, we wouldn't be here! And now she wants to act innocent while the two of us die?!'

After taking a deep breath, the male bandit exclaimed, "That bitch is lying! She's with us! She was the one who suggested we rob you guys, too!"

The female bandit gritted her teeth in anger, but she wasn't willing to give up just yet.

"That's preposterous! He's only saying that because he's jealous I chose Qin Kai over him! He's been eyeing me since the beginning, too!"

"She's lying! Her real name is Zou Nuying, and she has a high position within the Gold and Money Bandits! The reason she went to make love with Qin Kai was so that she could distract him while we robbed the Huang Family!"

"Is that so? What do you have to say to these accusations, Zou Nuying?" Huang Chen glared at her with killing intent within his gaze.

Zou Nuying swallowed nervously. She knew that she was done for and that there was no way for her to talk herself out of this situation.

Therefore, she decided to escape.

"Watch out! He's going to attack!" Zou Nuying suddenly shouted while pointing at her companion.

Everyone there subconsciously turned to look.

'This is my chance!'

Zou Nuying suddenly retrieved two smoke bombs and smashed them on the floor, instantly filling the room with smoke that also contained some kind of material that weakened the spiritual energy in the area and even blocked Yuan's divine sense.

She proceeded to rush towards the window, but since the entire place was filled with smoke, she could only rely on her memories.

Once she could feel the window, she smashed right through it with her body and escaped the hotel.

Yuan wanted to chase after her, but he didn't want to leave the Huang Family behind, and he had to make sure the other bandit didn't try to do anything funny.

"Is everyone okay?!" Huang Xiao Li's voice resounded shortly after.

"Yes, I am okay."

"Me too."

Everyone there confirmed their safety.

Once the smoke finally cleared, Yuan asked, "What should we do with him? I can kill him here if you want."

"I want all of his information before we kill him. Dong Zhou, make him talk!"

"Yes!" Dong Zhou proceeded to drag the bandit to another room, where he would torture the bandit for all of his information.

Meanwhile, Huang Chen went to speak with the hotel managers to let them know of the situation.

The servants in the hotel cleaned up the mess and the corpse without much trouble.

Once everything was done, Huang Chen thanked Yuan for his efforts, "Thank you, Yuan. If it hadn't been for your sharp eyes, our Huang Family would've ended in a tragedy. I will definitely reward you handsomely at the end of our trip."

Yuan shook his head and said with a smile, "I am only doing my job as a bodyguard."

"What should we do about the one who ran away?" Dong Zhou asked.

"I don't want to waste time and resources looking for her in this vast place. She could be anywhere by now. However, if we run into her again, immediately kill her." Huang Chen said.

"Yes!"

"What should we do now? We're down to three bodyguards..." Madam Huang asked sometime later.

"Dong Zhou and Qin Kai can stay here and protect you here. Since we have taken care of the bandit situation, I doubt anyone else would try to attack you guys. The one who escaped won't dare to return, either. I can protect Senior Huang by myself when he goes outside." Yuan said.

"I will also pay the hotel extra for their security service." Huang Chen said.

"What about me? I also want to go with you guys!" Huang Xiao Li suddenly asked.

"Only if you promise to not cause any trouble."

"What?! Since when have I caused any troubles?!"

"Always." Huang Chen smiled.

Sometime later, Huang Xiao Li approached Yuan and asked him, "Want to look around the city with me? I have already asked my father for permission."

He turned to look at Huang Chen, who nodded his head with a bittersweet smile on his face.

"Alright, let's look around."

"Please take care of my daughter, Yuan." Huang Chen said to him before they left the hotel and started wandering the city.

"What do you think about the Giant's Continent so far?" Huang Xiao Li asked him as they looked around.

"It's very unique, that's for sure." He said.

"Not just the environment, but even the people are vastly different from each other. Honestly, it feels like I am in a dream."

Huang Xiao Li chuckled and spoke, "That's what I felt during my first visit to this place. However, while it's nice to visit this place, I wouldn't want to

live here for too long. It's simply too dangerous for human cultivators, and only powerful cultivators would dare to wander outside the cities."

Sometime later, the two of them stopped when they noticed a group of giants surrounding what appeared to be a massive platform.

"What are they doing?" Yuan asked when he saw this.

"Ah, there must be a match going on right now," she said.

"A match? In the middle of the city?"

"Yes. One thing you should know about giants is that they love to fight, so there are platforms placed all around the city."

Yuan suddenly recalled the Ancestral Dragon Temple in the Ancient Dragon City.

The two of them approached the crowd to get a closer look at the match.

Once they were close enough, they could see two giants fighting each other with their bare fists. No weapon or armor could be seen.

The two giants threw fists at each other like their lives depended on it, and every time their fist struck its target, a weak ripple would sweep the place.

'Wow... What tremendous strength...' Yuan thought to himself as he watched the giants plummet each other until one of them could no longer stand.

Once the match ended, the winner shouted, "Who also wants to experience my strength?! I welcome all challengers! The winner will receive a Divine-rank body refining technique!"

Yuan raised an eyebrow after hearing the giant's words.

'A Divine-rank body refining technique? That sounds like something that could benefit me...' He thought.

"Don't tell me you're thinking about fighting him..." Huang Xiao Li suddenly said, almost as though she could see his thoughts.

"I wouldn't suggest it. You're not allowed to use any offensive techniques or treasures, so you can only fight him with your body. That giant must also be hiding his strength. After all, there's no way he would be willing to give away a Divine-rank technique so easily."

Yuan smiled and said, "It's fine. My body is sturdier than it looks. Even if I lose, I want to see for myself just how strong giants are."

He then jumped onto the stage and said out loud, "I will take on your challenge!"

The giants were stunned when a tiny human appeared on the stage, and after a moment of silence, they all burst out laughing.

Chapter 1019 - The Prowess of a Giant

Chapter 1019 - The Prowess of a Giant

"You, a mere human, wishes to challenge me, a giant, to a match of strength?! Ahahaha! This is the funniest joke I have heard all week long!" The 11-meters tall giant laughed out loud after being challenged by Yuan, his laughter causing the air to tremble.

"Why not? It's not our size that matters, but our strength, right?" Yuan responded with a calm smile on his face.

"Is this your first time to the Giant's Continent, little guy? Have you ever fought a giant before? Giants are at the top when it comes to natural strength! No human has ever beaten a giant when it comes to pure strength! I'm afraid that I might accidentally kill you if we fought! However, if you're still willing to take such a risk, then I will gladly be your opponent!"

"I am willing to take such a risk." Yuan nodded with confidence.

"Good! Then allow me to tell you some rules!" The giant said.

And he continued, "First of all, no weapons or treasures of any kind are allowed! If you have any on your right now, put them away!"

Yuan nodded and stored the Invisible Dragon Cloak into his Dragon Spatial Ring.

"Two! You are not allowed to use any offensive techniques! However, defensive techniques are allowed!"

"The third rule is that you are not allowed to dodge! You will have to endure every blow with your body! The same goes for me!"

"Final rule— the first one to give up or fall unconscious will lose!"

"Now that you know the rules, do you still wish to continue? I will give you one last chance to walk away, human brat!"

Yuan smiled and said, "It feels weird that you're addressing me in a way that makes it seem as though you're not human. I mean, I get it. Your ancestors transformed your blood through a godly technique, but it's not like you're no longer human. Unlike a demon, you still look human to me."

The place turned silent after Yuan's little speech.

'Oh no... That idiot!' Huang Xiao Li cried inwardly after sensing the change in the atmosphere.

Unbeknownst to Yuan, it was an unspoken rule within the Giant's Continent that you're not supposed to call giants 'humans'.

"How... dare... YOU!!! How dare you call me a human!" The giant on the stage suddenly roared with a red face.

"I take back what I just said! You're not allowed to quit anymore! We're going to fight to death now!" He roared, causing the air to tremble.

The giants watching the match began shouting like a group of warriors before a big battle, causing the ground and buildings there to shake violently.

Yuan was a little surprised by the giants' reaction.

'They're offended because I called them humans? What a blunder. Now I have a target on my back,' he sighed inwardly after realizing the situation.

"Are you ready to fight?!" The giant asked him sometime later.

"Yes, I am ready." He nodded.

"THEN HERE I COME!"

The giant wasted no time throwing his first punch, and a fist the size of a large boulder flew at Yuan's small figure in comparison.

Although he was unable to dodge the attack, the giant didn't say anything about not being able to strike back, so he also threw his own punch, putting all of his strength behind it.

The moment their fists connected with each other, a powerful ripple swept the scene, surprising everyone there. Though what shocked them even more was the fact that Yuan, a mere human, was not only able to survive the giant's attack but even stop it. **FREE WEB NOVEL**

However, it was not perfect. Yuan had been pushed back several steps while the giant remained unmoving like a mountain.

'Looks like I have underestimated the strength of giants...' Yuan thought to himself after feeling a numbing sensation in not only his fist but the rest of his arm as well.

Furthermore, he's already used all of his strength in that last exchange, yet he couldn't push back the giant even slightly. The chances of him winning this match in his current state was slim to none.

Despite that, Yuan didn't give up, and he was even smiling.

'It's been a while since I have faced such a strong opponent— an opponent that I cannot defeat easily! This is great!' He laughed inwardly.

The giant was also quite surprised when Yuan managed to stop his fist.

'Even though his attack seemed ordinary and ineffective, the spot he struck felt like it had been stabbed with a needle and actually hurts like hell! Where did such a formidable human come from?!' He cried inwardly but acted completely tranquil outside.

"You... I don't think I have heard your name yet. I am known as Sorgi."

The giant suddenly introduced himself as Sorgi.

"My name is Yuan."

"Good! Now let's continue our fight!" Sorgi laughed as he threw his fist at Yuan for a second time.

"Ha!" FREE WEB NOVEL

Just like their last confrontation, Yuan blocked Sorgi's first with his own, but he was forced several steps back again.

"Let's see how long you can keep this up!" Sorgi roared as he threw the third strike without giving Yuan any time to rest, then a fourth, and a fifth.

Huang Xiao Li and the other giants watched with their mouths wide open, not daring to believe their eyes.

"Do you think he's cheating?" One of the giants there suddenly threw out this thought.

"He's definitely cheating! There's no way a human like him could rival a giant in raw strength! He must be hiding a treasure somewhere in his body!"

When the giants started accusing Yuan of secretly using a treasure, the match stopped temporarily.

"You think I am cheating?" Yuan looked at the crowd of giants with his eyebrows raised slightly.

"Of course! Otherwise, how else can you hold your own against a giant?! Not even body refiners are capable of such a feat!" The giants responded.

"Is that so?" Yuan mumbled.

He turned to look at Sorgi and asked him, "What about you? Do you think I am cheating?"

Sorgi frowned after hearing this question.

Although he didn't want to accuse Yuan of cheating, his pride as a giant didn't think it was possible for a human to match him.

"I see..." Even though Sorgi hasn't said a word yet, Yuan already knew the answer by looking at the expression on his face.

"If you think I am cheating, then I don't mind letting you search my body. I will even hand over my clothes and spatial rings to my friend during the match. What do you think?" He suggested.

"There's no need to search your body." Sorgi responded after a moment of silence.

And he continued, "But you can leave your clothes and spatial ring with your friend. If you can prove to everyone here that you're not cheating, I will compensate you for this misunderstanding."

"Very well." Yuan nodded.

He proceeded to remove his clothes until he was wearing nothing but his underwear, revealing to everyone there his sweaty but refined body.

Even Sorgi was surprised when he saw Yuan's body that looked like it had been carefully sculpted by the heavens itself.

"Xiao Li, can you hold these for me for a bit?" Yuan asked her, who was blushing from ear to ear after seeing his half-naked body.

After handing Huang Xiao Li his clothes and spatial rings, Yuan returned to the stage with only his underwear.

"I am ready." He said with a cold expression on his face.

Sorgi swallowed nervously, and he could feel an uneasy feeling welling up inside his guts.

The two of them continued to throw fists at each other shortly after.

'T-This is! He's gotten even stronger than before! How is this possible?!'
Sorgi was shocked inwardly after sensing the immense force behind Yuan's first strike after the brief break.

However, that was not the end of his shock, as Sorgi could feel Yuan's attacks continuously growing stronger with every strike.

As time passed and the number of strikes they threw at each other increased, Yuan's eyes started turning golden, and his body began emanating an unfathomable aura that made it seem as though an unparalleled entity had descended from the heavens.

Soon even, Yuan's body was enveloped by a golden aura that made him feel invincible— like he was an unrivaled god.

When Sorgi and the spectators saw this, they all subconsciously swallowed nervously.

'What kind of technique is he using?! I have a really bad feeling about this!'
Sorgi cried inwardly as he stared at Yuan's shimmering figure.

Chapter 1020 - Golden Mountain

Body Refinement

Chapter 1020 - Golden Mountain Body Refinement

"I don't know what kind of trick you're using, but you won't be able to defeat me!" Sorgi roared as he used his own body refining technique, increasing his prowess by many folds, and his body began pulsating with energy so powerful it became visible to one's eyes.

However, Yuan remained calm, his gaze as tranquil as a still lake.

"Haaaaaa!" Sorgi threw his most powerful strike yet, causing the air to tremble.

"Ha!"

Yuan also threw his own fist, his aura skyrocketing right before it collided with Sorgi's fist.

Boom!

The entire city shook as a massive ripple swept the city, and one of them flew off the stage and into many buildings before stopping.

The giants were shocked and speechless after seeing the results.

"S-Sorgi lost to a human!" One of them exclaimed, his eyes filled with disbelief.

"Impossible! What happened just now?! How can a mere human have such prowess with such a tiny body?! This doesn't make any sense!"

After sending Sorgi flying off the stage, Yuan closed his eyes and took a deep breath, and he could feel the invincible feeling in his body quickly dissipating.

He looked at his hands with a wondering gaze.

'Just on earth was that strength? I experienced it during my fight with Li Jinxi before. If only I can control this power...' He sighed inwardly.

Sometime later, Sorgi returned to the stage with a blooded arm.

"Are you okay?" Yuan asked him, feeling a little bad about injuring him to such an extent.

"My muscles are torn, and my entire arm is broken, but I will be fine after some medicine." Sorgi said with a calm smile on his face.

"Giants are tough, I'll give you that." Yuan smiled back.

"Yuan, right? Here is your reward." Sorgi handed him a scroll with his other hand.

"Thank you."

After accepting the scroll, Yuan immediately opened it and memorized the content.

"Relax, I wouldn't scam you with a fake technique before so many people." Sorgi misunderstood his actions.

"By the way, there will be a major tournament next month that is held by the royal family. It's going to be something like our match just now, and I think you'll do great in it. Perhaps you might even win the grand prize, which is a Mythic-rank body refining technique." Sorgi suddenly said.

"What? A Mythic-rank body refining technique?" Yuan's eyes widened with surprise.

However, as much as he wanted to participate in the tournament, he will have to leave the Giant's Continent with the Huang Family in 14 days.

"I would love to participate, but unfortunately, my time here is limited, so I won't be able to participate."

"That's a pity. I wanted to see how you would fare against the best warriors in the Giant's Continent." Sorgi shook his head.

Sometime later, Yuan retrieved his clothes and spatial rings from Huang Xiao Li, who was staring at him with admiration.

"Yuan! You totally overwhelmed that giant! I still can't believe it! How do you train your body?!"

"It's nothing fancy. I just temper my body with medicine." He calmly said.

"Those must have been some expensive treasure since you were able to defeat a giant using your raw strength."

"No, my strength is actually weaker than Sorgi. Something else allowed me to defeat him." He shook his head.

"Huh? What?"

"I don't know. I am also trying to figure it out."

"Let's continue our tour for a little more before we head back to the hotel." Huang Xiao Li suggested.

"Sure."

Meanwhile, somewhere in the Giant's Continent, a giant that had been sitting on a throne as large as a mountain slowly opened his eyes, his gaze filled with dominance.

'That aura just now...'

The giant slowly stood up and turned to face the direction of the Southern Stronghold.

"Ah... Have you finally returned, my old friend? I have been waiting for this day ever since I perfected the Great Mammoth Body Refinement. I will not lose this time!"

This giant suddenly bent his knees in a way that looked like he was prepared to jump, and the next moment, he jumped, soaring towards the Southern Stronghold faster than a rocket.

About an hour after Yuan fought with Sorgi, he returned to the hotel with Huang Xiao Li.

"Father! Mother! You will not believe what happened when we were outside! Yuan fought with a giant and won!" Huang Xiao Li bragged about his match with Sorgi the moment she returned home.

"What?! He fought a giant?! What happened?! Are you guys okay?!" Huang Chen misunderstood the situation and panicked.

After all, if a human picked a fight with a giant while they were in this place, nobody would be able to save them if the giants decided to destroy them.

"It's fine, father. It wasn't a fight. It was a legit match. Yuan even won a Divine-rank technique from it." Huang Xiao Li cleared up the misunderstanding.

"Seriously? Yuan, you're truly full of surprises."

"It's nothing much," he said with a smile.

"Anyways, I am going to study this new technique that I acquired. If you need me, don't hesitate to interrupt me." He said to them before going into another room.

Sometime later.

[You have learned Golden Mountain Body Refinement]

[Golden Mountain Body Refinement]

[Rank: Divine]

[Mastery Level: 1]

[Description: Strengthens your body to become even tougher than that of a mountain made of pure gold!]

After learning the technique, Yuan stood up and tried it.

[Golden Mountain Body Refinement!]

After activating the technique, Yuan could see a thin layer of golden light protecting his body, and he could also feel his body getting stronger.

'In order to train body refinement techniques, I will need people to hit me while I am using the technique...'

He went to grab Huang Xiao Li a moment later.

"What happened to the technique?" She asked him.

"I have already learned it," he calmly said.

"Y-You what? There's no way you learned a Divine-rank technique in less than an hour!" She exclaimed.

Yuan didn't say anything and decided to prove it by showing her the technique.

"You actually managed to learn it in under an hour...? Now that I think about it... You're also a quick learner when it comes to array symbols..." She muttered in a dazed voice after seeing the golden glow protecting his body.

"I want you to hit me as hard as you can." Yuan suddenly said to her.

"Sure." Huang Xiao Li did not hesitate and prepared to throw her fist at him.

However, he quickly stopped her and said, "Hold it! Why are you using your hand? Use a weapon instead. You're going to break your hand like that!"

"What? Did I hear right? You want me to strike you with a weapon?" She looked at him with wide eyes.

"Don't worry, I will be fine. Even if I am not fine, I won't blame you for it." He said with a smile.

"That doesn't make me feel any better, but whatever. I trust you."

Huang Xiao Li proceeded to retrieve a Heaven-grade sword and slashed it at Yuan with all of her cultivation behind it.

Ding!

The sword bounced off Yuan's body the moment it touched the golden layer.

"This isn't too bad. I don't have my Invisible Dragon Cloak on right now so I was expecting to bleed a little." Yuan said after seeing the results.

"You were expecting to bleed?" Huang Xiao Li's jaw dropped a little after hearing such words.

"Looks like I will need something stronger if I want to cultivate this technique properly. I should pick a fight with another giant and use them to train this technique." Yuan said with a weird smile on his face.

"I won't say anything as long as it's a match and you're not actually picking a fight..." Huang Xiao Li said.

"Anyways, let's—"

BOOM!

The entire building suddenly shook violently.

"An earthquake?" Huang Xiao Li looked around with a raised eyebrow.

"No, this isn't caused by an earthquake. It's too unnatural." Yuan said.

Everyone in the hotel proceeded to look outside the window, and to their absolute shock, a giant that size of an actual mountain had suddenly appeared outside the city.

"Holy shit..." Yuan muttered in a dumbfounded voice when he saw the size of this giant.

If he stood before this giant, he would figuratively and literally be like an ant.

"What are they doing?" Huang Xiao Li pointed at the giants in the street, as they had all suddenly dropped to their knees and kowtowed towards the giant outside the city.

Her question would be answered the following moment when every giant in the city could be heard shouting—

"We pay respects to His Majesty, Giant Emperor Kulas!"

The entire city shook for a second time when all of the giants there paid their respects to Giant Emperor Kulas, who was the current ruler of the Giant's Continent.

However, Giant Emperor Kulas ignored the giants and swept the city with his gaze. Every single individual that entered his gaze trembled with awe.

A few moments of silence later, Giant Emperor Kulas spoke in a deafening voice, "How long do you plan on hiding?! I know you're here! Tian Yang, get your ass out here and fight me!"

Yuan's eyes widened with shock when he heard the name 'Tian Yang' come out of the Giant Emperor's mouth.

'This is Tian Yang's memories?! I thought this was the God of War's memories! And what relationship does he have with the Giant Emperor?! The Giant Emperor looks pissed!' He cried inwardly, not daring to respond to the Giant Emperor's call, as that would be akin to suicide with his current strength.

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Chapter 1021 - Giant Emperor Kulas

Chapter 1021 - Giant Emperor Kulas

"Tian Yang! Get your ass out here! I won't move a single inch until you come out and fight me like a man! Or have you become a coward since our last duel?!" Giant Emperor Kulas roared when Yuan didn't respond to his callings.

The giants in the city were baffled by the Giant Emperor Kulas' words.

In their eyes, Giant Emperor Kulas was the strongest giant in their race. He was a proud warrior with a godlike physique that has never lost a fight before. While many giants would challenge him, they don't recall the last time he personally challenged another person to a fight.

And judging by his recent words, it seemed that Giant Emperor Kulas was desperate to fight this individual known as Tian Yang.

However, nobody there knew of a giant by that name.

"Do you know of a Tian Yang?"

"No, I don't."

The giants in the city mumbled to each other while Giant Emperor Kulas stood before their city, his gaze sweeping through it.

"Just who is this Tian Yang, and why does the Giant Emperor want to fight him?" Huang Xiao Li mumbled in a dazed voice as she stared at the massive giant standing outside the city.

"Who knows..." Yuan shrugged.

Despite being very confident in his own strength, Yuan knew that he was not an opponent for Giant Emperor Kulas, who appeared to be above Spirit Sovereign.

Therefore, he decided to ignore Giant Emperor Kulas' entire existence by pretending to not see him.

"I'm going to cultivate." Yuan said as he returned to his room.

However, he would soon realize that was an impossible feat with the Giant Emperor shouting his name every few minutes.

"Tian Yang! You dare ignore me?!"

"Get your ass out here!"

"Tian Yang!"

"I have all day!"

"I will stand here until you leave!"

Giant Emperor Kulas made it impossible for the residents of the city to have a peaceful mind and impossible to cultivate. However, none of the giants complained. They wouldn't dare to complain even if Giant Emperor Kulas decided to erase their city from the continent.

In the Giant's Continent, Giant Emperor Kulas was nature and the law. Whatever he says goes.

However, while the giants could not do anything about Giant Emperor Kulas, they could do something about this Tian Yang.

"This Tian Yang is ignoring His Majesty's summoning and making His Majesty wait! The audacity!"

"Yeah! Let's find this bastard for His Majesty!"

"Drag out this Tian Yang from whatever rathole he's hiding in!"

Eventually, all of the giants in the city began looking for this Tian Yang.

"I think this Tian Yang is a human!"

"Yeah! No giant would ever disobey His Majesty so openly!"

"Gather all of the humans in this city! We must find this Tian Yang at all cost!"

The giants in the city began gathering all of the humans they could find outside the city, where Giant Emperor Kulas was waiting.

"Yuan! The hotel staff are telling us that we need to gather with the other humans outside the city!" Huang Xiao Li called for him outside his room.

"Seriously?" Yuan rubbed his eyes in a stressful manner after hearing her words.

'Is it impossible to avoid the Giant Emperor? Do I really have to fight him?' He wondered as he opened the door and went outside.

"It's alright, you guys can stay here." Yuan said to the Huang Family after leaving his room.

"Huh? Did you not hear me? They want every human in the city to gather outside the city! They could kill us if we refuse! This is all because of Tian Yang who's been ignoring the Giant Emperor!" Huang Xiao Li gritted her teeth in frustration.

"I'm telling you that it's fine. Nothing will happen. Because I am Tian Yang." Yuan revealed this fact to them.

"Y-You're Tian Yang...?" They all stared at him with shocked faces.

"Well... I am Yuan, but I am also Tian Yang. It's a nickname." He said with a bittersweet smile.

"Isn't this your first time to the Giant's Continent? Why would you know the Giant Emperor if that was the case? And why are you avoiding him?" Huang Chen frowned, becoming suspicious of Yuan's identity.

"This is really my first time coming to the Giant's Continent. As for the Giant Emperor... I met him outside the Giant's Continent. And the reason I am avoiding him is because I don't want to fight him." Yuan shrugged, making up all sorts of excuses.pa da ov l

"Anyways, since they're going through this much trouble to bring me out, I will go have a chat with the Giant Emperor."

"Yuan! Whatever you do, do not offend the Giant Emperor! He is literally 'Heaven' to the giants! You don't want to offend someone like him, especially not in his territory!" Huang Xiao Li warned him.

"I won't." Yuan said before flying out of the window and towards the giant outside the city.

When Giant Emperor Kulas saw Yuan flying towards him, he started laughing out loud, "There you are, Tian Yang! Did you not hear me calling for you? Why were you hiding from me? Did you not want to fight me?!"

The giants in the city stopped their movements after hearing Giant Emperor Kulas' words, and they all silently spectated the situation.

"I'm here on private business, so of course I don't want to fight you. I don't want to attract too much attention, after all." Yuan said.

"Hahaha! That's a load of bullshit! If you didn't want to fight me, why would you use that technique?! You're clearly provoking me!"

"Technique? What technique?" Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"Still acting dumb? Or do you believe that I had forgotten about it? Too bad for you, I have never forgotten about that golden aura of yours since our last fight! I came here the moment I sensed it!" Giant Emperor Kulas said.

Yuan's eyes widened with surprise after hearing the true purpose of Giant Emperor Kulas' visit.

'He came here because he sensed my golden aura? Does he know something about it? If he does, I must ask him!'

This is the first time that someone besides Tian Yang knew something about his golden aura, and this could be his opportunity to learn something about it.

"Since you seem to know so much about the golden aura, why don't you tell me everything you know about it? If you do, I will fight you."

Giant Emperor Kulas did not immediately respond to him.

After a moment of silence, he spoke, "I didn't notice it at first due to my excitement, but what happened to your cultivation base? Why are you so pitifully weak? I wouldn't enjoy beating you in your current state."

Yuan pondered for a moment before speaking, "I was injured not long ago, and that affected my cultivation."

Giant Emperor Kulas narrowed his eyes at Yuan.

"Forget it then. I don't want to fight you in your current state. Come back when you're stronger."

And without saying anything else, Giant Emperor Kulas turned around and walked away, leaving Yuan utterly speechless.

'This fucker! How can he leave things like this?! He came here so suddenly and even caused such a commotion! Is the Stairway to Heaven trying to tease me?!'

However, Giant Emperor Kulas stopped after taking a few steps.

He turned around and looked at Yuan.

"My family is hosting a tournament next month. If you win it, I will tell you everything I know about the golden aura. See you there."

After saying such words, Giant Emperor Kulas leaped into the sky and disappeared into the horizon.

'The tournament? Unless it's going to happen in the next trial, I will most likely have to wait until I ascend to the Fourth Heaven...' He sighed inwardly.

Yuan returned to the Huang Family shortly after.

"Are you okay? What happened? Why did the Giant Emperor leave so suddenly?"

"It's nothing much. He wants me to participate in the tournament next month—the one Sorgi talked about. However, that isn't possible since I will be leaving this place with your family before it can happen."

Huang Xiao Li immediately began pondering.

After a moment of silence, she turned to look at her father and spoke, "Father, I have a request!"

"I think I have an idea about what you're going to ask me, but ask away anyway..."

"Let's stay in the Giant's Continent for a little longer! We can leave after the tournament! I really want to see Yuan fighting against the other giants, especially after what I witnessed today! It's going to be amazing!"

Huang Chen sighed after hearing his daughter's request.

He turned to look at Yuan and asked him a moment later, "What do you think? Do you want to participate in this tournament? Since the Giant Emperor is expecting your presence there, I cannot be the reason why you miss it."

Yuan nodded, "I would like to participate in the tournament."

"Then it's settled. We'll stay here for a couple more weeks." Huang Chen declared.

"Thank you, Senior Huang." Yuan said to him.

"There's no need to thank me. You saved my family's lives more than once, after all. And I also want to see how you will fare against the strongest giants in the continent. However, since the location of the tournament is a little far away, we will need to start making our way there right now if we want to make it there in time for the tournament. As for my business, it can wait until we reach the capital. I will have a higher chance of acquiring more valuable treasures over there than here." Huang Chen said.

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Chapter 1022 - Tournament of Strength

Chapter 1022 - Tournament of Strength

"What about the ship? It will leave with or without us in 14 days, right?" Yuan asked.

"Yes, but it will return in 7 days for another 14 days. If we miss that, we can wait for the next one. It's really not that big of a deal. Most people that come to this continent tend to stay here for over a month, too." Huang Chen said.

"Alright."

The Huang Family quickly packed their stuff and checked out of the hotel.

When they left the hotel, everyone in the street would stop whatever they were doing to stare at Yuan.

However, nobody there dared to approach him.

"Is that him? The human that His Majesty had challenged?"

"Yes, that's him."

"Where do you think he's going?"

"According to the rumors, His Majesty is expecting to see him at the tournament next month."

"What? A human participating in the Tournament of Strength? That's ridiculous."

"Who knows. A human recognized by His Majesty isn't someone we should look down upon."

Sometime later, Yuan's group stopped by a large building.

"Since we're going to be traveling a long distance, we'll need to rent a carriage and hire a driver." Huang Chen said.

"I can pay for it since I'm the reason we're making the journey." Yuan said.

"It's fine. I got it." Huang Chen smiled at him.

Half an hour later, Huang Chen returned to them and said, "They're preparing the carriage and our driver. They should be ready in an hour. Until then, let's go get something to eat."

"Sure."

They walked around until they could find a restaurant that was operated by a human, as the restaurants for giants were simply too big for them.

Huang Xiao Li remembered Yuan's monstrous eating habits and ordered a full table of food just for him.

As they began eating, giants would gather outside the restaurant and peek inside, all of them seemingly there to look at Yuan.

"That's Tian Yang? What's so special about him?"

"I don't know."

"Hey! I recognize him! He fought with Sorgi earlier today and won!"

"What?! Sorgi?! Seriously?! He's one of the strongest warriors in this city!"

"So what if he beat Sorgi? Compared to the warriors that will be attending the Tournament of Strength, Sorgi is no different than an ant."

"He didn't just beat Sorgi. He overwhelmed Sorgi, even breaking his arm! Although it was even at first, he suddenly used a mysterious power that still sends shivers down my spine when I recall it."

Yuan ignored the giants watching them from outside like they were part of some kind of exhibit. However, the Huang Family was quite nervous from all of the staring.

After eating, Yuan and the Huang Family made their way to the gathering point, where a large carriage made for giants was already prepared for them.

"That's going to be dragging the carriage?" Yuan was expecting horses, but he got something entirely different.

"Yes, that's a Green Earth Dragon. They may have the word dragon in their name but they're really just large lizards. Horses aren't used here because they're too weak for giants." Huang Xiao Li explained.

"Are you guys ready?" The driver, a 7 meter-tall male giant, asked them.

"Yes, we're ready." Huang Chen nodded.

The giant nodded back and commanded the Green Earth Dragon to move, dragging the carriage away from the Southern Stronghold and towards Colossal Mammoth City.

"How much do you guys know about the tournament?" Yuan asked the Huang Family as they moved.

"Not much except that it's the biggest event in the entire continent that only occurs every hundred years." Huang Chen said.

"I believe it's called the Tournament of Strength. The strongest warriors from around the world will participate in it. The winners will not only receive a powerful technique but also the title of Colossal, something that can only be held by the strongest person in the continent."

"If you win this tournament, you can expect unimaginable wealth and fame within the Giant's Continent. Rumors even say that you'll be able to join the Royal Family by marrying one of their princesses." Huang Xiao Li added.

"The Royal Family... That would be the Giant Emperor's family, right?" Yuan asked for confirmation.

"That's right. Giant Emperor Kulas is not only the strongest entity in this world but also the most influential. His words are the law and his actions are akin to nature. Nobody dares to oppose him."

"Do you think you'll be able to win the tournament?" She asked a moment later.

Yuan immediately shook his head with a bittersweet smile, "In my current state? I don't think so."

"Really? Even though the Giant Emperor wanted you to participate?"

"I have no idea what that guy has in his mind." He shrugged.

Sometime later, the driver suddenly shouted, "We have incoming magical beasts!"

They stopped talking and looked in front of them, where a single beast that stood on two legs could be seen blocking the road.

"That's a Wingless Dragon! And it's emitting the strength of a Spirit Emperor!" Qin Kai exclaimed.

"If there's only one of them, I can handle it." Yuan said as he leaped from the carriage and into the sky, where he quickly charged up a Heaven Splitting Sword Strike.

Whoosh!

The Wingless Dragon was consumed by the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike, disappearing alongside the road, where a large crater now existed.

The giant stopped the carriage for a moment to look at Yuan with wide eyes, seemingly not daring to believe his eyes.

Once Yuan returned to the carriage, the giant continued to drive the carriage.

"Wow! That was amazing!" Huang Xiao Li exclaimed.

"If only you could use spiritual attacks at the tournament, you would definitely win!"

"If only..." He smiled.

'If I want to win the tournament, I will need to temper my body even more. If only I could use the golden aura at will... Since I cannot do that, I will need to think of another way to increase my chances of winning...'

After pondering for some time, Yuan recalled the nameless technique being trained by Li Jinxi.

'Perhaps I can use that temporarily...' He thought inwardly.

Chapter 1023 - Unbearable Pain

Chapter 1023 - Unbearable Pain

Yuan closed his eyes and began reciting the nameless technique inside his head.

About an hour later, the Huang Family could see a red aura emanating from Yuan's body, and he gave off the feeling of a wild beast who thirsted for blood.

"Y-Yuan? Are you okay?" Huang Xiao Li asked him in a nervous voice, as the pressure coming from him was quite overwhelming.

He opened his eyes and nodded with a calm expression, "Don't worry, I am fine. It's just a new technique that I recently learned."

Meanwhile, in the spectator's room, Li Jinxi stared at Yuan and his red aura with wide eyes.

"That red aura looks very familiar..." Chu Liuxiang mumbled out loud when she saw it.

"It's my technique." Li Jinxi said.

"Huh? You taught it to him? When?"

"When he started training me. If he understood my technique, then he would be able to train me better. I didn't think he would want to learn something like that because he said that it wasn't created for humans— not that I am complaining. Since I gave him the technique, I don't mind if he uses it as well."

"A technique not created for humans? Can you use it for me? I would like to see it." Feng Yuxiang suddenly asked.

"Sure." Li Jinxi nodded.

She proceeded to activate her nameless technique, showing off her red aura that looked just like the one surrounding Yuan at this moment.

"I see... The Young Master is right. This technique does give off a beastly vibe, and it's a fairly strong one. Is it a Divine-rank technique?"

Li Jinxi nodded, "My family always thought it was only a Heaven-rank technique for some reason."

It wasn't until she learned the technique in Cultivation Online that she found out the technique was actually a Divine-rank technique and not a mere Heaven-rank technique.

"Do you know what kind of beast this technique was created for?" Li Jinxi asked.

Feng Yuxiang narrowed her eyes and pondered for a moment before speaking, "I have a feeling that I have encountered that kind of aura before, but I cannot remember when or where. Sorry."

"It's fine." Li Jinxi shook her head.

"Do you know the origin of the technique?" Feng Yuxiang then asked.

"I do not. It's been with my family since ancient times."

"Your surname is Li, right? If I recall correctly, there is a well known family with that surname in the Third Heaven, and they're all beast tamers that utilize the power of beasts. Maybe they know something about it."

"I guess we'll find out when we get there."

Half an hour later, Yuan's carriage encountered another magical beast.

This time, he did not use Heavenly Splitting Sword Strike. Instead, he used the nameless technique and confronted the magical beast head-on with the Empyrean Overlord.

Sha!

The Empyrean Overlord sliced through the magical beast as though it was tofu, and Yuan noticed his aura growing a little stronger when he killed the magic beast.

[Nameless Technique]

[Rank: Divine]

[Description: Increases your overall strength and removes the limit on your body to a certain extent.]

The Nameless Technique was a simple yet profound technique that is more than it appears.

Yuan looked at the red aura that covered his body after killing the magical beast, feeling an overwhelming sense of strength.

However, right as he was getting comfortable with the nameless technique, Yuan suddenly felt an intense sensation of pain coming from his heart, almost like he was having a heart attack.

He immediately knelt on the ground and clenched his chest.

"Argh!" He screamed out loud.

The pain coming from his heart was many times stronger than his worst body tempering session, and it felt like his heart was being torn apart.

"Yuan?! Are you okay?!" The Huang Family was shocked when they saw this.

However, Yuan did not hear them speaking at all, as a deafening voice was resounding inside his head at this moment.

'How dare you use another aura when you already have Heaven's Supremacy!'

This deep voice sounded very familiar to Yuan, but he does not recall where he had heard it— not that he was in the condition to ponder.

The Huang Family then watched as a golden aura began emanating from Yuan's body, quickly consuming the red aura.

Eventually, the red aura was completely replaced with the golden aura.

The pain stopped shortly after, and Yuan was finally able to take a deep breath.

'What the hell happened just now?! What was that voice?!' He cried inwardly, his body soaked in cold sweat as the painful sensation still lingered in his body.

"Yuan!" Huang Xiao Li jumped off the carriage and rushed over to see his condition.

"Your face is so pale! What happened to you?!" She was shocked when she saw his ghastly complexion.

"I think I experienced some kind of backlash... I should be fine after some rest..." He said.

Huang Xiao Li supported Yuan with her shoulder until they returned to the carriage.

"Here, eat this Spirit Replenishing Pill. It should help you." Huang Chen handed him a pill that restored his spiritual energy.

Even though he barely used his spiritual energy, Yuan still consumed the pill, and he could feel a burst of refreshing energy spreading throughout his entire body.

While he rested, Yuan tried to recall where he had heard that voice before.

'That's right! I remember now! I heard that voice during one of my dreams!' He finally recalled.

However, that only made the situation even more puzzling.

'Why did I hear that voice just now? It mentioned Heaven's Supremacy... Is that the name of that mysterious aura?' He wondered inwardly as the carriage continued moving.

'The voice sounded angry when I used the nameless technique... Almost like it has its own consciousness, but how is that possible?'

Yuan pondered and pondered, but he was unable to understand with this tiny amount of information.

'Should I use the nameless technique again to see if it will happen again?' He wondered inwardly, yet he was hesitant to do so, mostly because he didn't want to experience that unbearable pain again.

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Chapter 1024 - Soul Strength

Chapter 1024 - Soul Strength

'No, I shouldn't use the nameless technique again— at least not now. We'll need to settle down somewhere before I try again.' Yuan thought to himself.

After all, if he tried using the nameless technique and loses consciousness due to the backlash, he wouldn't be able to protect the Huang Family and fail the Stairway to Heaven.

Fortunately for Yuan, his headache vanished half an hour later, and his pale complexion was also restored back to normal.

"You shouldn't use that technique again. I think there might be something wrong with it." Huang Xiao Li warned him.

"Alright," he nodded with a bitter smile.

As they continued their journey to Colossal Mammoth City, Yuan would protect the carriage from all sorts of magical beasts with most of them having the strength of a Spirit Emperor.

'These trials are getting too ridiculous too quickly. I am only trying to ascend to the Third Heaven and I am already forced to fight Spirit Emperors. At this rate, I will have to fight Immortals if I wish to ascend to the Fourth Heaven.' Yuan sighed inwardly.

"How are you feeling, Yuan? I'm sorry you have to endure all of this all by yourself. I would love to help, but I am simply powerless in this place." Huang Xiao Li felt a little guilty when she saw how Yuan was dealing with all of their threats all by himself.

"Don't worry about me. I am the reason we're making this unnecessary trip in the first place so it's only reasonable for me to bear the responsibility and protect all of you."

"By the way, how far are we from our destination?" He turned to ask the driver.

"At the pace we're moving, we should arrive in 20 days."

"20 days, huh?"

Yuan didn't say anything else and closed his eyes to cultivate.

For the next four days, Yuan would do nothing but protect their carriage from magical beasts.

At the end of the fourth day, the driver said to them, "There's a city up ahead. If you wish to take any breaks, now would be the time. We won't see the next city for another week after this one."

"I would like to take a bath and eat some food!" Huang Xiao Li immediately said.

"Do you mind if we stop here for a bit, Yuan?" Huang Chen asked him.

"You don't need to ask me, even if you want to stay here for a night or two." Yuan said.

"Alright, then we'll stop here for a couple of hours before we continue our journey." Huang Chen nodded.

Once they arrived at the city, the driver said to them, "I will wait for you here. Take as long as you need."

"Are you sure? You can take a break as well." Huang Xiao Li said to him.

"Thank you for your consideration, but I take my job very seriously. I won't leave this carriage until I bring all of you to Colossal Mammoth City."

"I understand."

Sometime later, the Huang Family rented a hotel room for one day, allowing everyone to enjoy a hot bath.

"Ah! That felt great!" Huang Xiao Li exclaimed in a satisfied voice after coming out of the bathroom with a towel wrapped around her body, her hair still dripping wet.

Huang Chen frowned when he saw her appearance, and he said, "You're not at home. Mind your appearance!"

"Oh, right..." Huang Xiao Li quickly went back into the bathroom to dry her hair and wear clothes.

After leaving the hotel, they went to a nearby restaurant and ate until all of their stomachs were bloated.

They returned to the driver waiting outside the city afterward, continuing their journey for another 7 days.

The magical beasts they encountered during these seven days were stronger than the previous encounters.

'The magical beasts are getting stronger as we get closer to the Colossal Mammoth City, but my strength isn't increasing... Unless I consume a monster core or a demon core, I won't be able to suddenly increase my strength to pass the trial like last time.'

On their fifth day to their 2nd checkpoint, the carriage came to a complete halt when a magical beast that stood on two legs with a pair of closed wings behind its back blocked their path.

"That's a Mountain Dragon!" The driver appeared to be terrified of this magical beast.

Just as the name sounds, this magical beast was like a small mountain that blocked their path.

'I will need to use the God of War's Astral Arts if I want to deal with this beast...' Yuan sighed inwardly after sensing the overwhelming aura coming from the magical beast.

"I will be right back." Yuan said to the Huang Family as he flew into the air and used God of War's Astral Arts.

"W-What in Kulas' name is that?!" The giant cried out loud when he saw the massive figure that appeared out of the blue in the sky.

Then he watched as the golden armored figure flattened the Mountain Dragon with a single strike, causing the entire world to tremble as well.

It wasn't just the driver. Even the Green Earth Dragon pulling their carriage was shocked by what it had just witnessed. It has seen many things throughout its life as a carriage puller, but it has never met a human with such prowess before.

Yuan returned to the carriage shortly after killing the Mountain Dragon with a pale complexion.

"Are you sure you're not pushing yourself? At this rate, you won't have enough strength left for the tournament..." Huang Xiao Li sighed as she positioned Yuan's head to rest on her soft legs.

"That technique uses my soul strength instead of my spiritual energy, so I will be fine as long as I get enough rest," he said.

"Soul strength, huh?" Huang Xiao Li suddenly put on a pondering face.

She turned to look at Huang Chen and asked, "Father... Don't you know any arrays that could help replenish his soul strength?"

"Actually, I do." He nodded.

"Really?" Yuan was pleasantly surprised to hear this.

"Yes. Give me a minute." Huang Chen nodded as he began creating array symbols that Yuan didn't recognize.

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Chapter 1025 - Soul Nourishment Array

Chapter 1025 - Soul Nourishment Array

After spending a few minutes creating array symbols, Huang Chen pointed his hands at Yuan and gestured for the symbols to activate, "Soul Nourishment Array!"

The array symbols surrounded Yuan and illuminated a beautiful golden light.

Although the difference wasn't anything major, Yuan's soul strength was definitely recovering noticeably faster.

"How do you feel, Yuan?" Huang Xiao Li asked him.

"This array is really useful. I've been thinking about getting a soul cultivation technique, but this could work as well— at least temporary. Do you mind teaching me this array? I'll be able to use my trump card much more often if I have this array. Of course, it's okay to refuse. I am aware that it's a valuable array since anything that can restore soul strength is valuable." He asked Huang Chen.

"I don't mind teaching you the Soul Nourishment Array, but will you even be able to use it? It's a level 4 array combination that's even more difficult than some level 5 array combinations." Huang Chen said.

"Level 4 array combination... I only know up to level 3 array symbols..." Yuan sighed.

"You can always learn level 4 array symbols. I mean, you're a quick learner and a genius Array Master. Here, you can have this." Huang Xiao Li handed him a thin book that read '2,000 Master Array Symbols'.

"Thank you!" Yuan accepted the book and immediately started flipping through the pages to memorize the content.

Since there were only 2,000 array symbols, it didn't take long for him to memorize all of them.

"Here's the Soul Nourishment Array." Huang Chen handed him the array combination next.

"Thank you." Yuan also memorized the array combination right after acquiring it. Since he couldn't take these items outside the Stairway to Heaven, he needed to memorize them before the trial ended.

While Huang Chen maintained the Soul Nourishment Array, Yuan would study the level 4 array symbols.

They continued this until they finally arrived at their second checkpoint.

"Do you wish to rest here like before?" The driver asked them.

"Yes, please."

"Alright."

Once the carriage was parked, Yuan and the Huang Family entered the city to take another break.

Shortly after Yuan and the others entered the city, a tall figure wearing a cloak approached their carriage, where the driver was patiently waiting for their return.

"Hey, I have some questions for you." The cloaked figure asked the driver.

'A woman?' The driver raised his eyebrows after hearing her clear voice, and judging by the size of this figure, she appeared to be human.

"What kind of questions?" The driver asked.

The woman proceeded to ask him several questions.

"Sorry, but I cannot answer these questions." The driver politely refused this mysterious woman after hearing her questions.

The woman sighed, "I didn't want to do this but..."

The driver immediately prepared to retaliate after hearing this woman's ominous words.

"Calm down. I'm not here to fight," she said after seeing the driver getting defensive and all.

"I'm going to show you my face. Don't shout too loudly." The woman said as she removed her hood just enough to reveal her facial appearance to the driver.

"Y-You're?!" The driver's eyes widened with shock upon realizing the identity of this woman.

"Shhh!" The woman quickly shushed him with a finger between her lips.

"Now tell me what I want to know," she then said.

"Alright..." The driver couldn't refuse her after recognizing her identity.

After spending several hours inside the city, Yuan and the Huang family returned to the carriage, but to their surprise, there was someone they didn't recognize with the driver, mostly because they were wearing a cloak that hid their face and identity.

"Who are you?" Huang Chen asked this cloaked figure.

"Hello, my name is Xie Mey. I have been looking for you, Tian Yang." The woman suddenly introduced herself.

Yuan frowned slightly and said, "I'm Yuan."

"Then why did you answer the Giant Emperor, who was calling for Tian Yang?" She asked with a smile.

"What do you want from me?" He asked.

"Nothing, really. I'm just interested in you, who has managed to receive the Giant Emperor's attention. As far as I am aware, the Giant Emperor isn't interested in weaklings. In fact, he wouldn't even acknowledge one's existence until they prove their strength. However, you have not only managed to attract his attention but even make him personally visit you. That's the first time I've seen him do something like that."

"You're going to Colossal Mammoth City for the Tournament of Strength, right? Do you mind if I tagged along? I promise that I won't be a bother. In fact, I'll even help out with protecting the carriage. I may not look like it, but I'm pretty strong." Xie Mey made a gesture that one would normally make to show off their biceps, but the cloak hid everything.

Yuan narrowed his eyes at this mysterious woman.

'I cannot sense her cultivation base, but she's definitely not a mortal, so she must be above Spirit Emperor. It would be a great help if someone like her joins our journey.' He thought to himself.

Furthermore, it was not as though he had the power to stop this woman from following them if she really wanted to.

"Do you mind if she joined us?" Yuan turned to look at the Huang Family.

"If you're okay with it, I won't say anything." Huang Chen said.

Yuan turned to look at the driver, who immediately nodded his head.

'The driver is acting weird... Does he know this woman?' Yuan thought to himself after noticing the nervousness within the driver's gaze.

"Alright, you can follow us." Yuan said to Xie Mey a moment later.

"Thank you, Tian Yang!"

"Call me Yuan. That is my name." Yuan corrected her.

"Okay, Yuan! Nice to meet you!"

They returned to the road sometime later but now with a new addition—this mysterious woman named Xie Mey whose motives were as mysterious as her identity.

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Chapter 1026 - Mysterious Woman

Chapter 1026 - Mysterious Woman

After leaving the city, the driver said to them, "There won't be any more stops until we reach Colossal Mammoth City now."

"Alright."

Yuan said as he pulled out the level 4 array symbols manual and started studying it.

Xie Mey, who has been staring at him since they got on the carriage, suddenly asked, "What are you doing?"

"I'm learning array symbols. I will need all of the concentration I can get before we're attacked by magical beasts, so if you don't mind, don't bother me until I am done. You promised that you wouldn't be a bother, right?"

"Eh? That's not fun! Let's talk a little before you focus on that book!" Xie Mey said.

"Hey! Stop bothering him or I will kick you out of here!" Huang Xiao Li interrupted with a slight frown on her face.

The driver in the front snapped his head and looked at Huang Xiao Li with wide eyes.

'Oh my god! She just threatened her!' He cried inwardly.

Xie Mey turned to look at Huang Xiao Li and smiled underneath her cloak.

"You'll kick me out? How are you going to do that? A mere Spirit Grandmaster, I can crush you with a single pinky." Xie Mey showed Huang Xiao Li her pinky and even wiggled it around in a provoking manner.

Yuan suddenly sighed and looked away from his book to look at Xie Mey.

"Did you come here just to pick a fight? If that's the case, let's get this over with."

Although he wasn't confident in beating her, he had a chance if he could catch her off guard with the God of War's Astral Arts.

"Relax, I don't want to fight you— at least not right now."

Yuan narrowed his eyes at her words that implied that she wanted to fight him at a later date.

"The Tournament of Strength. I will be participating in it as well. As much as I want to fight you now, I will wait until we both enter the stage," Xie Mey said.

"You're also participating in the Tournament of Strength? I understand Yuan's reason for joining, but you as well? Aren't you a human?" Huang Xiao Li was surprised to hear that a female human wanted to join the Tournament of Strength.

"So what if I am human? There are no rules that prohibit humans from participating in the Tournament of Strength. In fact, many humans participate in every tournament. Though no human has ever won the tournament before."

"A female body refiner, huh... How rare..." Huang Chen mumbled.

"Anyways, I just want to talk a little. I will stop bothering you afterward. Please?" Xie Mey said a moment later, even clasping her palms together in a pleading gesture.

"Fine. What do you want to talk about?" Yuan agreed to her proposal.

"How did you meet the Giant Emperor?"

"That's a secret between us." Yuan made up an excuse since he didn't know.

"Fair enough. Then why does the Giant Emperor want to fight you?"

"I don't know. Go ask him. He's the one who challenged me." He shrugged.

"I can't argue that... Alright then— why did you come to the Giant's Continent if not to participate in the Tournament of Strength?"

Yuan pointed at the Huang Family and said, "I am here as their bodyguard, and they're here to exchange their treasures."

"Seriously...? That's why you're here?" Xie Mey mumbled in a dazed voice, seemingly in disbelief.

After asking Yuan several more questions, Xie Mey finally stopped bothering him.

However, it didn't take long before he was distracted again.

The moment he sensed a magical beast nearby, Yuan dropped the book in his hands and retrieved the Empyrean Overlord. His movements were incredibly fluid and without any hesitation, almost as though he's done this a thousand times before.

[Vanishing Ghost's Soundless Blade!]

Yuan's arms flickered and disappeared for a split second, and in a speed that nobody there but Xie Mey could see, he sliced the magical beast over a dozen times, separating its body into many pieces.

"Not bad." Xie Mey praised him after he returned to the carriage.

"Thanks." Yuan casually said as he picked up his book and began reading again.

An hour later, Yuan sensed another magical beast approaching their location.

"I got this one."

Xie Mey suddenly said, and she left the carriage before Yuan could even stand up.

Yuan and the others watched as Xie Mey flew at the magical beast before giving it a single punch.

Although the punch looked ordinary, there was actually an immense force behind it, and when the fist connected with the magical beast, it blew a massive hole in the magical beast body.

"What?!" Huang Xiao Li's eyes widened with shock after seeing how little effort Xie Mey exerted to defeat the Spirit Emperor magical beast.

After killing the magical beast with a single punch, Xie Mey returned to the carriage.

"What do you think? Do you think you'll be able to survive my fist? By the way, that wasn't even half of my full power." Xie Mey said.

Although he couldn't see it, he was sure that there was a smug smile on her face right now just from her voice alone.

"Aren't you ashamed to be asking a mere Spirit Lord such a question when you're above Spirit Emperor?" Yuan asked her.

"Can a mere Spirit Lord kill a Spirit Emperor magical beast with such ease?" She responded with a question.

"I can tell that you're not using all of your power. I think I understand why the Giant Emperor took interest in you, but you're nowhere near the level to fight him, so I'm a little puzzled why he would challenge you."

Xie Mey suddenly looked around in a suspicious manner.

A few moments later, she spoke, "Now that we're pretty far away from the city, it should be fine if I show my face."

And without any warning, she removed the cloak that had been hiding her appearance this entire time.

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Chapter 1027 - Colossal Tower

Chapter 1027 - Colossal Tower

Yuan's eyes widened with surprise after Xie Mey removed her cloak, but it was an unexpected one.

'Who?' He raised his eyebrows after seeing Xie Mey's appearance without recognizing her.

Xie Mey was an incredibly beautiful woman with blonde hair and green eyes. She had a slim hourglass figure, and her breasts were quite ample. Her facial features were sharp and symmetrical, and her face gave off the aura of a battle-hardened warrior who has survived many battlefields.

Yuan thought that the trend of meeting people with similar faces that he already knew like Meixiu in the first trial would continue in the second trial, but that did not seem to be the case.

"I can tell that you're charmed by my beauty, but I'm sorry, I will only seriously consider someone who is stronger than me to be my partner!" Xie Mey suddenly said.

Yuan raised an eyebrow and said, "No, I just don't understand why you decided to hide your identity. I thought you were someone I knew, but that doesn't seem to be the case."

"I have my own reasons for hiding my identity."

Yuan casually shrugged and proceeded to ignore Xie Mey, returning to his study.

"Nobody here recognizes me? Seriously?" Xie Mey muttered in a dumbfounded voice when even the Huang Family began ignoring her.

"I-I recognize you..." The driver said in a low and somewhat nervous voice.

However, Xie Mey didn't even look at him, almost as though she didn't even acknowledge his existence.

Several days later, the carriage came to a stop when they finally arrived at their destination, Colossal Mammoth City.

Xie Mey, who was back to hiding her appearance, said to them, "The last few days were fun. Thank you for letting me tag along. I would love to continue tagging along, but I have to prepare for the Tournament of Strength, so we will have to go our separate ways here."

"While I still don't know who you are or your purpose for following us, I am glad that you did, as we have managed to arrive at our destination in one piece. It would've been really dangerous for us if I had to deal with all of the magical beasts by myself." Yuan said to her.

"I'm sure you would've managed it even if you had to do it by yourself. Anyways, I will see you later, Yuan. Don't disappoint me at the tournament. I really look forward to exchanging fists with you."

Xie Mey disappeared into the city shortly after, followed by Yuan and the Huang Family.

"We have a little over a week until the tournament. I am going to use this time to exchange my treasures." Huang Chen announced to everyone there.

Once they rented a hotel, Yuan followed Huang Chen and Huang Xiao Li to exchange their treasures while Dong Zhou and Qin Kai stayed back to protect Mistress Huang and her son.

Since this was their first time coming to the Colossal Mammoth City, Huang Chen had to spend some time gathering information about the best

places to exchange treasures.

"Then you are most likely looking for the Colossal Tower. It's the hottest location in this city when it comes to treasures. Most visitors go there to exchange their treasures as well."

"Thank you for the information. Here's a token of my gratitude." Huang Chen handed some gold to the person that provided him with the information.

Meanwhile, Yuan looked around with a pondering face.

"The giants in this place are noticeably larger than the ones in the last two cities." Yuan mumbled.

"Of course. This is the capital of the Giant's Continent, not to mention the upcoming tournament. All of the strongest giants in the continent will be gathered in this city." Huang Xiao Li said.

"I am aware of that, but I didn't think there would be such a vast difference."

"Just wait until the tournament. You'll be like an ant compared to most of them."

Sometime later, they arrived at the Colossal Tower, and just as its name suggests, the place was enormous, and it was one of the biggest buildings Yuan had ever seen in his life.

The building was so tall that he couldn't see the top even with his head tilted all the way back.

"I can't imagine how much effort and resources the giants had to spend to build this magnificent tower. I have always wanted to see it after hearing about it during my first time on this continent." Huang Chen sharply sucked in a bunch of cold air before mumbling in a dazed voice.

They entered the building sometime later.

"Make sure you don't wander and you keep your focus. It's actually very common for humans to die here, and most of them are accidents caused by giants and humans when we fail to pay attention to our surroundings. We're like ants in this place, after all." Huang Chen warned them.

Huang Xiao Li swallowed nervously and immediately stuck to Yuan.

"Do you mind if we hold hands?" she asked him, acting like a child who did not want to be separated from her parents by accident in a large shopping mall.

"Sure." Yuan nodded and held onto her soft hands.

Their group began wandering the tower, approaching every store that caught Huang Chen's attention.

Yuan didn't do much besides pay attention to their surroundings to make sure they don't get stepped on by accident.

As for Huang Xiao Li, she was focused on the sensation around her hands, feeling like she was on a date with Yuan.

Over the next couple of hours, they would go through dozens of stores and even some personal vendors.

At the end of the day, Huang Chen managed to exchange almost a dozen treasures.

"This place is truly heaven-sent! The quality of treasures in this place is incomparably superior than the ones found in Southern Stronghold! Extending the business trip was definitely worth it! Hell, I might even do this every time I come to the Giant's Continent now!" Huang Chen had a wide smile on his face as they exited the tower.

Chapter 1028 - Colossal Tower (2)

Chapter 1028 - Colossal Tower (2)

Over the next few days, Yuan and the Huang Family would return to the Colossal Tower early in the morning to exchange treasures until it was late at night.

As the days got closer to the day of the Tournament of Strength, there were noticeable more giants that were above 15 meters walking around the city.

"At this rate, I will be done with my business by tonight." Huang Chen said to Yuan as they left one of the stores in the Colossal Tower.

"Yuan, you know you can exchange treasures with the giants if you want. It would be a shame to leave this place without a souvenir, too." Huang Xiao Li said to him.

"It's really fine. I don't have any treasures to exchange, anyways." He shook his head.

He obviously had plenty of treasures for trade, but since this was only a trial and nothing was real, he wouldn't actually gain anything from exchanging treasures, and such actions would only cause him to lose a treasure without anything in return.

At the end of the day, Yuan and the Huang Family made their way towards the exit of the Colossal Tower after Huang Chen exchanged the last treasure he had.

"Now that I am done with my business, there's only the Tournament of Strength left before we head back home." Huang Chen said.

And he continued, "Thank you, Yuan, for all of your effort. Really, I cannot thank you enough for everything you have done for my family."

"I am just doing my job."

"No, you've done more than that. I will compensate you properly once we get back to the hotel. I have the best reward for you."

Once they exited the Colossal Tower, Yuan's group came to a sudden halt when a group of giants wearing armor blocked their way.

"What's happening?" Huang Xiao Li looked around with an uneasy face.

However, before Huang Chen could even say anything, a familiar voice resounded, "That's them! They're the ones that are conspiring against the Giant Emperor!"

Yuan turned to look at the voice to see a human woman pointing at them with a terrified look on her face.

It was Zou Nuying, the bandit who became the Huang Family's bodyguard to steal their treasures.

'She followed us all the way here? How did I not notice her?' Yuan wondered inwardly.

"I will need all of you to come with me. We will kill you if you resist." One of the giants there said to them in a cold voice.

"Wait! This is a huge misunderstanding! That woman is lying! She's actually a bandit that we failed to kill when she tried to steal from my family! She's part of an infamous group of bandits called the Gold and Money Bandits! We only came here to exchange treasures!" Huang Chen exclaimed with a pale face.

"Hmph! I don't care about your situation! We take all accusations that could bring harm to His Majesty very seriously! We will determine whether you are telling the truth or not once we interrogate you!"

"Resist and we will kill you on the spot!" The giants pointed their massive weapons at Yuan's group.

Yuan narrowed his eyes at Zou Nuying, who had a subtle smirk on her face.

'How troublesome. These giants probably don't care about who is right or wrong. Their resolute and emotionless eyes tell me that they've already come to a conclusion—to kill all of us no matter if we are innocent or not to remove all risks. After all, we humans are nothing in their eyes.'

Yuan closed his eyes and took a deep breath before shouting out loud, "Giant Emperor Kulas! I know you can hear me! Get your ass out here, or I will never fight you ever again, much less participate in your stupid tournament!"

The place turned dead silent as everyone there stared at Yuan with wide eyes filled with shock, all of them seemingly in disbelief.

When the giants snapped out of their daze and realized that Yuan had just cursed their emperor, their faces immediately turned as red as a hot iron that had just left the fire.

Huang Xiao Li and her father fell to their butts from shock, and they both stared at Yuan with disbelief.

"This fucking idiot! He just sealed his fate!" Zou Nuying laughed inwardly.

"Blasphemy! How dare you curse at our emperor! A mere human! Even if the heavens forgive you, we giants will never forgive you!" The giants there roared, causing the entire city to shake.

"Die!"

The giant leading the armored giants suddenly swung his halberd at Yuan, causing the air there to tremble.

"Halt." A calm yet loud voice suddenly rumbled.

When the giant heard this familiar voice, his entire body immediately froze.

Everyone there turned to look at the direction of the voice to see a bulky man that was around 15 meters tall slowly approaching them.

This man had short golden hair and a pair of emerald eyes.

Yuan didn't recognize this man at first glance, but the giants there immediately recognized him even though he was much smaller than usual.

All of the giants in that area suddenly knelt on the ground and kowtowed to him while screaming, "This loyal subject pays respects to His Majesty!"

Giant Emperor Kulas, who was suddenly much smaller compared to their last meeting, nodded and spoke, "Stand back. That man is an acquaintance."

"Yes!" The giants did not question him and all stepped back, giving them room.

"Although your cultivation has weakened, your audacity remains unchanged. I was worried that you might have turned into a coward when you lost your cultivation. I'm relieved to see that was not the case." Giant Emperor Kulas said, seemingly not offended even though Yuan had cursed him out before so many giants.

"How did you know that I had been watching you?" he then asked.

Yuan smiled and said, "You can try to hide your aura all you want, but you can't hide the killing intent within your gaze no matter how hard you try. I noticed you even before I entered this city a week ago."

"Hahaha!" Giant Emperor Kulas suddenly laughed out loud.

Chapter 1029 - Perfect Tempering Ginseng

Chapter 1029 - Perfect Tempering Ginseng

"Don't misunderstand, Tian Yang. When I emit killing intent, it's not because I want to kill you. I only do it when I really want to fight someone, and I really want to fight you right now, but alas, you're not ready yet." Giant Emperor Kulas said after he stopped laughing.

"Anyways, what is going on here? What is the cause of this commotion? You better have a good explanation on why you summoned me."

"It's really simple..." Yuan proceeded to explain the whole situation to Giant Emperor Kulas.

"I see... Conspiring against me, huh? Well... Are you?" Giant Emperor Kulas asked Yuan with a calm expression on his face.

"What do you think?" Yuan responded with a question of his own.

A wide grin suddenly appeared on Giant Emperor Kulas' face.

"You're many things, but you're definitely not a backstabber."

He turned to look at Zou Nuying, who was on the verge of pissing herself right now from fear. She could've never imagined that Yuan would be buddies with Giant Emperor Kulas himself.

"The Gold and Money Bandits, huh? I have never heard of you losers, but you must be a bold bunch to dare to try and trick my guards." Giant Emperor Kulas sneered in disgust.

"Guards! Public execution!"

When Zou Nuying heard Giant Emperor Kulas' words, her face immediately paled.

"W-Wait! He's lying to you! I am not a bandit! I am really telling the truth! They're secretly plotting to harm you, Your Majesty!"

"How dare you, a mere human, try to trick us! Die, you bitch!" One of the guards there suddenly shoved his spear at Zou Nuying, piercing her stomach.

And before Zou Nuying could even react, another guard also moved into action, penetrating her shoulder.

Then another spear came flying at her.

Within seconds, seven spears skewered Zou Nuying's body without mercy.

"Die!"

The head guard swung his halberd, decapitating Zou Nuying the following second.

Yuan and the others there watched as Zou Nuying's head rolled on the floor like a ball.

Nobody there uttered a single word for the next few moments.

Giant Emperor Kulas was the first to speak again, and his voice boomed throughout the city.

"Heed my words! This young man here is my lifelong rival, Tian Yang! Nobody is allowed to touch him before the Tournament of Strength!"

"Yes, Your Majesty!"

The giants there had many questions, but nobody there dared to ask these questions.

Giant Emperor Kulas' words were the law. The moment he announces it, they lost all chances to dispute or question it.

"I look forward to your performance at the Tournament of Strength, Tian Yang. Don't disappoint me." Giant Emperor Kulas said to Yuan before turning around and walking away.

Yuan returned to the hotel with the Huang Family shortly after.

"You almost scared me to death back there, Yuan!" Huang Xiao Li confronted him with a puffed face, trying to look angry.

"Sorry, but I didn't have any time to explain."

"Fortunately it all worked out in the end. That could've been the end of all of us, after all." Huang Chen could finally take a breather.

Sometime later, Huang Chen stood up and approached Yuan.

"Yuan, this is for you."

He retrieved a small wooden box and offered it to Yuan, who raised an eyebrow.

"What is this?" he asked as he accepted it.

"Open it and see for yourself."

'Does this mean it's the end of the trial?' Yuan wondered to himself as he opened the wooden box.

However, it was not a golden orb inside the wooden box. Instead, it was red ginseng that was the size of an adult's finger and shaped like a human body.

"What is this?" Yuan asked again since he didn't recognize the treasure.

"That's a Perfect Tempering Ginseng." Huang Chen said with a smile on his face.

"Is that the Perfect Tempering Ginseng?!"

Inside the spectators' room, Feng Yuxiang exclaimed in a shocked voice after seeing the treasure.

"What kind of treasure is that?" Chu Liuxiang asked with a curious look on her face.

"Perfect Tempering Ginseng... It's a priceless treasure that was only available during the Primordial Era. In other words, they are no longer available— at least they shouldn't be."

"What are the effects of this Perfect Tempering Ginseng? Does it have anything to do with one's physique?" Li Jinxi asked.

She nodded, "The Perfect Tempering Ginseng will fix all imperfection within one's body and then refine it. It is a priceless treasure that will improve one's physique multiple times and is a legend that many body refiners spend their whole life chasing after even to this day."

"Even if it's indeed this Perfect Tempering Ginseng, does it really matter? I mean, we're still inside the Stairway to Heaven, so it's just an illusion." Meixiu suddenly said.

"Yes... You're right. We're still inside the Stairway to Heaven. I guess I got a little excited after seeing a legendary treasure. It's truly unfortunate." Feng Yuxiang sighed.

Meanwhile, Huang Chen just finished explaining the Perfect Tempering Ginseng to Yuan.

"Since you're going to participate in the Tournament of Strength, this Perfect Tempering Ginseng will benefit you greatly."

"Thank you..." Yuan said with a smile on his face.

'What a pity. If only this treasure was real.' He sighed inwardly.

"There's still a few days until the tournament. Go ahead and take this time to absorb the Perfect Tempering Ginseng." Huang Chen then said to him.

"Alright." Yuan nodded.

"Good luck!" Huang Xiao Li and the others said to him before he locked himself inside another room.

Yuan looked at the Perfect Tempering Ginseng in his grasp with a pondering look on his face.

"Ah, what the hell. There's no harm in trying it. Although this is just a simulation, all of the food that I ate had a taste to it and this is probably no different."

And without thinking any further, he tossed the Perfect Tempering Ginseng inside his mouth and started chewing on it.

'Ugh. It's so bitter.'

Yuan's body shivered after tasting it.

Once the bitterness disappeared, his body suddenly began heating up, and within moments, his body started steaming with smoke coming out of his pores.

This shocked Yuan, who did not expect anything to happen after eating the Perfect Tempering Ginseng.

'I need to cultivate!'

He tossed aside all questions in his mind and immediately sat down to cultivate.

Chapter 1030 - Perfect Physique

Chapter 1030 - Perfect Physique

"What's happening to Yuan? Why is his body steaming?! His skin is also red, almost like his blood is boiling!" Chu Liuxiang exclaimed after seeing the sudden changes to Yuan's body.

"Don't tell me that it was caused by the Perfect Tempering Ginseng? I thought treasures acquired inside the Stairway to Heaven won't affect one's body for real..." Lan Yingying muttered in a dazed voice.

"I have also never heard of this before. Just what is happening to the Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang had a profound frown on her face as she thought about the implications from the situation.

Meanwhile, steam continued to gush out of Yuan's pores like boiling water in a kettle, quickly filling the room and turning it into a sauna.

Although nobody there could see it, significant changes were benign made inside Yuan's body.

His muscles moved around as though they were alive, and his bones altered their own shape, becoming bigger and more sturdy.

His blood rushed throughout his body, feeling adrenaline like never before.

The Perfect Tempering Ginseng was not only altering his body and fixing all of its imperfection, but it was also strengthening his bones and muscles at the same time.

One would expect intense pain from the changes happening inside Yuan's body, but besides feeling a little hot, he felt not even the slightest of

unpleasant feelings.

Suddenly, the golden symbols that had embedded itself inside Yuan's body began emanating a profound light that made his body seem as though it was being protected by a layer of divine aura.

His spiritual veins and Dantian suddenly began expanding in size, becoming wider and allowing his spiritual energy to circulate throughout his body multiple times faster.

And while Feng Yuxiang and the other spectators couldn't see it through the reflection, Yuan's cultivation was actually starting to decrease!

His peak Spirit Lord cultivation quickly lowered to the first level, but it did not stop there and continued until it reached the first level of Spirit Grandmaster. Several more moments later, his cultivation went down to Spirit Master, and it would not stop until his cultivation reached the first level of Spirit Apprentice!

However, despite his cultivation lowering, Yuan's aura did not weaken at all. In fact, it even skyrocketed, becoming many times stronger than before.

Over the next several days, Yuan would sit in the steamy room without moving a single finger, almost as though he'd turned into a statue.

The Huang Family didn't dare to disturb him even though it was getting close to the tournament.

"The tournament is in two days, yet he's still holed up in his room. Hopefully he doesn't miss the tournament..." Huang Xiao Li sighed.

"The Perfect Tempering Ginseng is a miracle treasure that can turn even a trash cultivator into a dragon amongst dragons. I cannot even begin to imagine its effect on someone who was already a dragon to begin with." Huang Chen shook his head.

"I guess we'll find out when he—"

Huang Xiao Li stopped speaking when an unfathomable pressure suddenly enveloped the entire building.

"W-Who is emitting this pressure?!" Everyone in the hotel was shocked by the pressure that came out of the blue.

The pressure was so powerful that it made it hard for everyone in the hotel to breathe properly. Fortunately, this pressure disappeared as quickly as it appeared. However, even though it was just slightly, everyone that had a taste of this pressure would not stop trembling in fear.

Meanwhile, inside his now clear room, Yuan slowly opened his eyes, which glimmered with dominance.

<Your body has undergone a significant transformation, achieving perfection!>

<You have gained the title 'Perfect Physique'>

<Description: Having a perfect physique, your body will progress faster through body temperament, acquiring unimaginable strength>

He took a deep breath and stood up.

'I've gotten taller... My body feels as light as a feather, and my body is constantly absorbing spiritual energy even without needing me to do anything, almost as though I am cultivating just by breathing.'

Yuan looked at his own hands.

'My cultivation had somehow weakened to Spirit Apprentice, yet I feel even stronger than when I was a peak Spirit Lord. Is this also because of the Perfect Tempering Ginseng? But Huang Chen didn't mention anything about this...'

As he tried to comprehend the situation, his cultivation actually increased, reaching the second level Spirit Apprentice.

However, he did not get any notifications from the system, nor did his stats increase. Despite that, he could somehow still feel his body getting a little stronger.

'Forget it, there's no point thinking about it now. I'll ask Tian'er once I finish this trial.'

Yuan left the room shortly after.

"Y-Yuan...? Is that really you?" Huang Xiao Li's eyes widened with shock when she saw Yuan.

His appearance had changed so much that everybody there instantly recognized it the moment they saw him.

Not only did Yuan get taller, but his face was also much more refined and handsome, not to mention his body, which looked flawless even underneath his clothes.

"Heavens... You're almost like a different person..." Huang Chen mumbled in a dazed voice after seeing Yuan.

Huang Xiao Li approached Yuan until she was standing right in front of him.

"Y-You grew half a head in just a few days?! Is this the effects of the Perfect Tempering Ginseng?!" she exclaimed.

After swallowing nervously, she asked in a trembling voice, "D-Do you mind if I touch your body for a bit?"

Yuan smiled, "Go ahead."

Huang Xiao Li didn't hesitate and started squeezing his arms and legs with her hands.

'Wow! What perfect muscles! They feel soft yet firm at the same time! How is this possible?!' she cried inwardly as she squeezed his muscles as though she was kneading dough.

"Looks like the Perfect Tempering Ginseng worked like a charm on you."
Huang Chen smiled.

"Yes, and it's all thanks to you." Yuan bowed to him.

"Don't even mention it." Huang Chen shook his head.

Huang Xiao Li suddenly exclaimed, "Wait... What happened to your cultivation?! Why are you suddenly a Spirit Apprentice?!"

"What?!" Huang Chen's eyes widened with shock after hearing her words. He narrowed his eyes at Yuan, and sure enough, his cultivation was only at the third level Spirit Apprentice!

However, before he could even say anything, Yuan's cultivation suddenly increased to the fourth level right before his eyes!

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Chapter 1031 - Perfect Physique (2)

Chapter 1031 - Perfect Physique (2)

"Oh, yeah. I'm not sure what happened, but my cultivation was reduced to Spirit Apprentice after consuming the Perfect Tempering Ginseng." Yuan casually said, leaving them speechless.

"H-How can you be so calm about this?! You just went from being a peak Spirit Lord to a Spirit Apprentice! And the tournament is in two days! Even if you have a perfect physique, you won't be able to do anything in the tournament!" Huang Xiao Li exclaimed.

"The Perfect Tempering Ginseng reduced your cultivation? That's impossible! The treasure has no such side effects!" Huang Chen exclaimed in a panicked manner. After all, he would be responsible for Yuan's lost cultivation since he was the one who handed Yuan the Perfect Tempering Ginseng.

"Calm down. Although it's true that my cultivation is gone, my body feels a lot stronger than when I was a Spirit Lord. If you don't believe me, you can try hitting me. As for my spiritual energy... It won't take much effort for me to return to my original cultivation base." Yuan explained to them.

"Are you for real? You feel stronger even though your cultivation was reduced to such a state? What kind of phenomenon is this?" Huang Xiao Li mumbled in a dazed voice.

He nodded, "Go ahead. Hit me with your strongest attack. I will even remove my armor."

Yuan removed his Invisible Dragon Cloak and gestured for Huang Xiao Li to hit him.

However, Huang Xiao Li was hesitant to strike a Spirit Apprentice with her cultivation.

"Don't worry, I will be fine." Yuan showed her a confident smile.

She suddenly recalled how Yuan was able to defeat a giant with his raw strength.

"Don't blame me if you die from this!" Huang Xiao Li shouted at him before unleashing her strongest martial technique backed by her full cultivation base.

"Ha!"

Huang Xiao Li plunged her palms directly into Yuan's chest.

Boom!

The entire room shook for a brief moment from the impact, yet Yuan remained standing in the same spot without moving even a millimeter.

"No way..." Huang Xiao Li muttered with a baffled look on her face.

"See? I told you. I barely even felt your attack just now." Yuan said with a gentle smile on his face, treating Huang Xiao Li's attack as though it was a baby's playful punch.

"Does this mean you'll still participate in the Tournament of Strength?" Huang Chen asked.

"Of course." He nodded.

"Very well. Then you must restore your cultivation as soon as possible. If you need any help, we have plenty of treasures—"

Yuan raised his hand and gestured for Huang Chen to stop.

"You have already done enough by giving me the Perfect Tempering Ginseng. The tournament is in two days, right? Then I have plenty of time."

"If you say so." Huang Chen nodded.

Yuan returned to his room shortly after to cultivate.

'My cultivation speed is at least four to five times faster than before... At this rate, I should barely return to being a Spirit King right before the tournament.'

Thus, Yuan would spend the next two days cultivating nonstop.

Meanwhile, in the spectators' room, Chu Liuxiang mumbled in a dazed voice after seeing Yuan's new appearance.

"My god... I didn't think it would be possible for Yuan to become even more handsome than he already is, but he's exceeded my expectations!"

Meixiu didn't say anything, but her gaze when looking at Yuan was akin to a young maiden who was falling in love for the first time.

Li Jinxi swallowed nervously after seeing Yuan's new physique. In her eyes, that was the most attractive part of him, and she couldn't help but imagine how it looked underneath his clothes, causing her mouth to become watery.

"A-As expected of a legendary treasure... Only the Perfect Tempering Ginseng could possibly create such a miracle..." Feng Yuxiang sighed, feeling a little dejected that she couldn't get a closer look at the treasure.

"Hey, Meixiu, do you think this treasure will affect Yuan's real body?" Chu Liuxiang asked Meixiu in a low voice.

"I don't know... But considering how powerful the treasure is, I wouldn't be surprised if it does."

"I'm going to check his body! Be right back!"

Chu Liuxiang logged off Cultivation Online before Meixiu could even respond.

After removing her helmet, Chu Liuxiang turned to look at Yuan, who was sleeping right beside her.

'Hmm... He doesn't seem any different. Maybe it takes some time before the treasure affects his real body?'

Chu Liuxiang returned to the spectators' room shortly after.

"Nothing yet, but I won't lose hope just yet!" Chu Liuxiang said to Meixiu.

Two days later, Yuan stopped cultivating and opened his eyes.

'Peak Spirit Grandmaster, huh? I am on the verge of breaking through to Spirit Lord, so I might have a breakthrough during the tournament.' Yuan thought to himself after inspecting his own body.

He left the room to meet up with the Huang Family afterward.

"We're all ready to go. What about you, Yuan?" Huang Chen asked him.

"I am ready as well." He nodded.

"Good heavens, you've managed to increase your cultivation from Spirit Apprentice to peak Spirit Grandmaster in just two days? Just how monstrous are your talents?" Huang Xiao Li was baffled when she saw his cultivation.

Yuan and the Huang Family left the hotel and started making their way to the location of the tournament.

Although they didn't know where to go, they only needed to follow everyone else in the street, as they were all going the same direction.

After walking for almost two hours, they would eventually arrive at a massive square where a single colossal stage existed in the center.

However, there were so many giants in the square that all of the humans there had to fly if they wanted to see anything.

Not far away from the stage, there was a large platform supporting a colossal throne, where a handsome giant with golden hair sat. Of course, this man was Giant Emperor Kulas, and he had a bored expression on his face.

However, that changed when he noticed Yuan's presence somewhere in the crowd, and a wide smile appeared on Giant Emperor Kulas' face.

'Show me a grand performance, Tian Yang!'

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Chapter 1032 - Ancestral Tablet

Chapter 1032 - Ancestral Tablet

While Yuan waited with the Huang Family for the Tournament of Strength to begin, countless players in the Spirit Heaven were busy looking for the treasures that Yuan had hidden for his event.

Even though it has been over two weeks since Meixiu revealed the location of the treasures to the world on behalf of Yuan, only half of the treasures had been found, so the treasure hunt was still in progress.

In fact, the players' excitement and passion only grew stronger with every passing day.

However, because of this seemingly innocent treasure hunt, thousands of players have died to other players because whenever a treasure is found, there would be a massive war to acquire it.

Although it was never Yuan's intention to cause such chaos, what's done has already been done, and nobody blamed him for the chaos.

"Bastards! I found this treasure first! Get your hands off me!"

"Nonsense! It doesn't matter who finds it first! The last person to hold it will be the rightful owner!"

The residents of Spirit Heaven were dumbfounded by the commission caused by the players. In their eyes, most players were rouge cultivators, and it was not normal for so many rouge cultivators to gather in one spot, so they couldn't help but keep watch of the situation.

When the residents of Spirit Heaven realized that the players were looking for treasures, they also joined in on the fun.

Even though Yuan was no longer in Spirit Heaven, he was still causing mayhem there.

Meanwhile, Chairman Lee was laughing his ass off as he watched the chaos from a safe distance.

Since Yuan had given him special treatment for his help, he didn't need to fight for any treasures.

"I am truly thankful to Chairman Zhao for his foolishness! If he didn't offend Yuan, I wouldn't have taken his place and became friends with Yuan!" Chairman Lee laughed out loud.

Of course, Chairman Zhao was not the only one who had received special treatment.

White Lotus, Xia Jingyi, and Yu Rou also received their own Divine-grade treasures.

About ten minutes after Yuan arrived at the square with the Huang Family, Giant Emperor Kulas stood up from his throne and swept the crowd with his profound gaze.

The noise in the square immediately died down, and everyone there turned to focus on Giant Emperor Kulas

"Welcome to the Tournament of Strength, where the strongest warriors in the Giant's Continent are born. In the Tournament of Strength, only one thing matters— your physique and raw prowess." Giant Emperor Kulas' voice rippled throughout the whole city.

"There are only three rules in the tournament. One, you are not allowed to step on the stage with any treasures on your body. We have uniforms prepared for all participants. Besides this uniform and your own body, you will bring nothing else onto the stage."

"For the second rule, you are not allowed to use any martial techniques during the match. The only technique you are allowed to use are body enhancement techniques. In other words, anything that doesn't directly affect your body is strictly forbidden!"

"Last but not least, you are not allowed to consume any kind of medicine or pills during the match. Before the match begins, you are required to consume a Body Cleansing Pill, which will remove anything unnatural affecting your body, so any pills or treasures that you have consumed beforehand will be rendered useless."

"If you dare to disobey these rules and cheat before my presence, I will personally rip your head off your body. Did I make myself clear?" Giant Emperor Kulas narrowed his eyes at them.

"Yes, Your Majesty!" Everyone responded in a clear voice.

"Now then... As for the qualifications to participate in the tournament. I don't care if you're a human or a giant, if you can create even the slightest crack on this Ancestral Tablet, I will allow you to participate in the tournament for a chance to acquire the title of Colossal."

The next moment, Yuan watched as two massive giants wearing golden armor carried a large black boulder onto the stage.

Even though the boulder itself was smaller than either one of these giants, it required two of them to carry it.

"The Ancestral Tablet is made out of the most durable material that can be found in this continent, and it has a special property that gives them extreme resistance against spiritual energy, essentially making them invulnerable to all spiritual attacks. However, that doesn't make them vulnerable to physical damage. Not only are they durable against spiritual energy, they are also incredibly durable against physical damage. In order to participate in the tournament, you must strike the Ancestral Tablet with nothing but your fist and make a crack in it. Simple, right?"

Everybody there was left speechless by Giant Emperor Kulas' last words. Even though the task sounded simple, it was actually an incredibly difficult requirement that will eliminate the majority of people there today!

"I have one more announcement before we begin the qualifiers." Giant Emperor Kulas suddenly said.

And he continued, "The winner of this year's tournament will not only receive the title of Colossal and a Mythic-rank body refinement technique, he will also earn the right to take my youngest daughter as their bride."

"What?!"

Several people there exclaimed in a shocked voice after hearing such words.

'Giant Emperor Kulas has a daughter?' Yuan raised an eyebrow.

In the midst of the commotion, a figure suddenly appeared on the stage.

This person was an unbelievably beautiful woman with long golden hair and a pair of emerald eyes, but she did not have the physique of a giant.

Yuan's eyes widened when he saw this woman on the stage.

"T-That's Xie Mey! She was the Giant Emperor's daughter all along?!" Huang Xiao Li exclaimed beside him.

Indeed, this woman turned out to be Xie Mey, who had accompanied them to this city.

"Greetings, warriors. Just as my father said, I will consider marrying the person who will bear the title Colossal for the next 100 years." Xie Mey spoke in a gentle voice as she swept the crowd with her gaze, stopping when her gaze met Yuan's. When that happened, a bright smile appeared on her face.

'This woman...' Yuan shook his head inwardly, wondering why he didn't realize her true identity sooner when she had the same features as her father.

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Chapter 1033 - Ancestral Tablet (2)

Chapter 1033 - Ancestral Tablet (2)

"Good heavens, the winner of the tournament will have a chance to marry Princess Meiya? This means that the winner will not only become the next Colossal, but he will also join the royal family! This is a once-in-a-lifetime chance!"

The giants there were extremely excited.

"Princess Meiya? Is that her real name?" Huang Xiao Li mumbled in a pondering voice.

"Forget about her name. I am more interested in her figure." Yuan suddenly said.

"H-Her figure?! So you like women with that kind of body, huh?" Huang Xiao Li said as she stared at Meiya's hourglass body.

"Huh?" Yuan raised his eyebrows. "No, that's not what I am talking about. I'm wondering why her physique resembles that of a human when her father is that massive."

"Ah, I heard that female giants naturally have a smaller frame than male giants. Furthermore, I doubt that's her real size. The royal family has a body refining technique that can alter their body size." Huang Chen explained.

"I see... That's why Giant Emperor Kulas shrunk in size when I saw him again..."

Sometime later, those who wanted to participate in the tournament started testing their strength against the Ancestral Tablet.

"Ha!"

A 21 meter-tall giant stood before the Ancestral Tablet and punched it with all of his might, causing the entire thing to tremble.

However, that was all. The strike was strong enough to make the Ancestral Tablet tremble, but it wasn't strong enough to cause any damage to it.

"I-Impossible..." The giant muttered in a dazed voice as he stared at the spot he'd just punched, seemingly in disbelief.

"Get out of the way, you weakling!" The giant behind him suddenly pushed him aside and punched the Ancestral Tablet as well.

Dong!

The Ancestral Tablet shook violently.

The giant removed his fist from the rock with a confident smile on his face, but when he couldn't see any cracks on the Ancestral Tablet, his complexion paled.

"Hahaha! Don't open your mouth if you have no strength to back it up! Get out of my way!"

One by one, both giants and humans would take their chances at the Ancestral Tablet.

However, even after going through hundreds of participants, not a single person has managed to damage the Ancestral Tablet.

An hour later, someone finally managed to damage the Ancestral Tablet, and it was a female giant.

"S-She really did it! She cracked the Ancestral Tablet!" The judge overseeing it announced after seeing the small crack on the rock.

Shortly after the female giant cracked the Ancestral Tablet, the damage actually restored itself until it looked brand new.

'What interesting material...' Yuan thought to himself, and he imagined making an armor out of it.

Sometime later, after thousands of people had gone on the stage, Yuan finally decided it was his turn to approach the stage.

However, the moment he stepped on the stage, Giant Emperor Kulas' voice resounded, "You don't need to qualify for the tournament, Tian Yang. You'll participate in the tournament regardless of your result."

"..." Yuan turned to look at Giant Emperor Kulas with raised eyebrows.

"Is he the rumored rival of His Majesty? I heard about him."

"Me too... I wonder how strong he is..."

The people there mumbled to each other.

"Even if you say that, I want to test my strength." Yuan suddenly said.

Giant Emperor Kulas narrowed his eyes and pondered for a moment before silently nodding his head.

Yuan approached the Ancestral Tablet the next moment and prepared to strike it.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan punched the Ancestral Tablet with all of his strength.

BOOM!

The entire arena shook when Yuan's fist landed on the Ancestral Tablet.

It was clear to everyone there that Yuan's strike was the strongest thus far. However, when Yuan removed his fist from the Ancestral Tablet, everyone was shocked to see not even the slightest crack on it.

Giant Emperor Kulas' narrowed his eyes at the Ancestral Tablet.

'Not bad...' A smile appeared on his face for some reason.

Yuan stared at the rock with a pondering face, and without saying anything, he turned around and walked off the stage.

"Looks like we have overestimated that human. He couldn't even do anything to the Ancestral Tablet. He doesn't qualify to participate in the tournament, but since His Majesty gave him special treatment, he'll still be able to enter... How unfair."

The giants there complained amongst themselves in a low voice, especially those that had failed to pass the qualifications. They despised Yuan for being allowed to participate in the tournament even though he clearly didn't qualify.

However, nobody there dared to complain out loud.

Sometime later, after several more people struck the Ancestral Tablet, the 13th person to go after Yuan's turn shocked everybody there with his results.

"H-He shattered the Ancestral Tablet! How is that possible?!"

"Holy heavens! I have never seen anything like this before!"

"Who is that man?! His prowess must be near His Majesty's level if he could destroy the Ancestral Tablet!" The spectators were in shock.

It was not just the spectators. Even the person who destroyed the Ancestral Tablet appeared to be quite shocked by the results.

Unbeknownst to these people, Yuan's strike had destroyed the core of the Ancestral Tablet during his turn, severely weakening the Ancestral Tablet, hence why this random person was able to shatter the rock even though his strike wasn't anything out of the ordinary.

Of course, Giant Emperor Kulas was aware of this, but he didn't say anything.

"What should we do now, Your Majesty? The Ancestral Tablet is broken and it'll take some time to prepare a new one." The judge asked him.

"There's no need. 40 people have passed the qualifications— that is more than enough. We will end the qualification here and begin the tournament."

"Yes!"

Once the stage was clean again, Giant Emperor Kulas called all 40 participants onto the stage.

The majority of the participants were unsurprisingly giants. As for humans, there were only four of them that had qualified, including Yuan.

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Chapter 1034 Number 3

Chapter 1034 Number 3

All 40 participants stood on the stage after Giant Emperor Kulas announced the end of the qualifiers when the Ancestral Tablet was destroyed.

"The 40 of you will now fight against each other until only one of you remains undefeated. We will decide the matches through a lottery system." Giant Emperor Kulas snapped his fingers, summoning someone onto the stage.

This person was holding onto a metal tray that had 40 storage pouches on it.

"Every storage pouch will have a number inside, from number one to twenty. Those that have picked the same number will be fighting against each other. Simple, right? Go ahead and choose your pouches."

Yuan and the other participants went to grab their storage pouch.

Once everyone had one in their grasp, they opened it to retrieve a piece of paper with a number on it.

'Number three...' Yuan read the number on his paper in his head.

"If your number is not one, get off the stage." The judge on the stage said to them a moment later.

Everyone there but the two male giants with the number one left the stage.

The judge handed each of them a Body Cleansing Pill to swallow and a pair of white uniforms to change into.

Once the pill took effect and they changed clothes, Giant Emperor Kulas signaled the beginning of the fight.

BOOM!

The two giants on the stage immediately began striking each other with their bare fist, each of their strikes causing the stage to tremble and creating ripples in the air.

Yuan swallowed nervously after seeing the fierceness of these giants. Compared to Sorgi, these two were on another level, perhaps several levels higher even.

"H-Hey... Yuan... Are you sure you'll be fine? Each of their strikes feels strong enough to shatter a real mountain..." Huang Xiao Li tapped his shoulders and asked him in a nervous voice.

"Let's hope so..." Yuan said with a bittersweet smile on his face.

Despite having a perfect physique, he wasn't completely confident in winning the tournament, as he had underestimated the difficulty of it.

Over the next two hours, the giants on the stage would repeatedly strike each other without stopping for more than a few seconds, almost as if they had unlimited stamina and their bodies were indestructible.

Their bodies began turning red after three hours, and in the fourth hour, the spectators could finally see blood being shed.

Yuan and the Huang Family expected the fight to end soon in their condition, but to their absolute shock, these two giants continued to abuse their bodies for another three hours.

The whole fight had lasted 7 hours, and by the end of the fight, not a single bone in their body was left unharmed with most of them shattered into many pieces.

"How in heaven's name will they continue to fight the next match in such a condition?" Huang Xiao Li mumbled to herself after seeing their broken

bodies.

It was a miracle that neither of them had died, but they were definitely on the verge of death.

"Winner— Warrior Kozus!" The judge announced.

After the fight ended, the judge handed both of the participants a pill that Yuan had never seen before.

During the next few minutes after they swallowed the pill, their bodies could be seen recovering at a rapid rate, and by the end, their bodies looked completely fine, almost as if the match had never occurred.

While the giants healed their injuries, some of the servants went on the stage to clean the blood until it was essentially new.

Once the first two participants left the stage, the next two entered the stage.

This time, it was a giant against a human— a female human at that. .

However, nobody there dared to ridicule the female human, as she had qualified to stand on the stage by cracking the Ancestral Tablet, something the majority of the people there had failed to achieve.

The two of them changed into a white uniform and consumed a Body Cleansing Pill a few minutes later.

After bowing to each other, they started punching each other.

The giant was over 20 meters tall while the female human was only around 1.65 meters— it was like watching an ant fighting an elephant. However, despite the difference in their sizes, the female human did not immediately lose to the giant and even gave up a good fight.

Although the fight lasted only half as long as the previous match, it was still very shocking to the spectators, as the female human had actually managed to defeat the giant!

"Winner— Warrior Mu Shiying!"

"She actually won..." Huang Xiao Li muttered in a dazed voice as she stared at the tall beauty standing on the stage, her body soaked in sweat and blood.

While the participants for the second match recovered their injuries, Yuan prepared to enter the stage.

"You're next, right?" Huang Xiao Li asked him.

"Yes, I am." He nodded.

"Then take this. It'll help you." Huang Xiao Li suddenly retrieved a wooden box from her spatial ring and handed it to him.

"Huh? You know I cannot use any treasures before the match." Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"Just take it." She urged him.

Yuan accepted the box and opened it.

His eyes widened when he saw what was resting inside the box.

"Good luck, Yuan." Huang Xiao Li said to him with a smile on her face.

"Yes... Thank you."

Yuan smiled back at her before absorbing the golden orb of light inside the box.

After absorbing the orb of light, Yuan could feel his muscles becoming even sturdier.

<+500,000 Physical Strength>

<+500,000 Physical Defense>

"The next participants may enter the stage!" The judge's voice resounded a moment later.

"I'll be right back." Yuan said to the Huang Family before approaching the massive platform, and he could feel the gaze of everyone there staring at him.

The moment he stepped onto the stage, the scenery began to change, and Yuan found himself back at the Stairway to Heaven a few seconds later.

"What a place to stop the trial..." he sighed out loud.

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Chapter 1035 Kulas

Chapter 1035 Kulas

"Congratulations on passing the second trial, Master." Tian'er appeared before him shortly after he returned to the Stairway to Heaven.

Yuan turned to look at her with a serious expression on his face, "Tian'er, I have some questions for you before I continue the trial. Why did the Perfect Tempering Ginseng affect my body even though that shouldn't be possible?"

Tian'er tilted her head and spoke in a calm voice, "Why shouldn't it be possible?"

"I mean... I get that I can learn techniques while inside the Stairway to Heaven, but the treasures affecting my actual body doesn't make any sense. Everything should be a simulation, so it shouldn't be possible to actually affect my body."

A profound smile appeared on Tian'er's small face as she spoke, "While it's true that the trials are all simulations created by the Stairway to Heaven... The treasures are actually real. The Stairway to Heaven is more than it appears. It's not only a bridge that connects the Nine Heavens, it's also a vault full of treasures stored by the previous Masters."

Yuan's body trembled in shock after hearing Tian'er's words.

"The Stairway to Heaven... is a treasure vault...?" he muttered in a dazed voice.

"That's right. However, only the Master has access to these treasures, hence why nobody is aware of it." Tian'er continued.

Yuan fell to his knees after learning the truth and coming to a realization.

'I could've acquired so many priceless treasures at the Colossal Tower, but I wasted such a chance because I assumed the treasures were fake! What a blunder!' he cried inwardly.

"Wait! Even if I didn't acquire the treasures during the trial, the treasure should still exist somewhere in the Stairway to Heaven, right?!" Yuan suddenly asked Tian'er.

She nodded and said, "If you wish to have access to the vault, you'll need to continue climbing the Stairway to Heaven, as this place is also a training device for you."

"I understand. Thank you for the explanation."

Yuan climbed the staircase shortly after, ascending to the third trial.

"This appears to be your final trial, Master." Tian'er said to him.

'Is this going to be a continuation of the previous trial? Or is it going to be something entirely different?' Yuan closed his eyes and wondered to himself as the scenery began to change.

When he opened his eyes, he found himself standing on a platform. However, the platform looked different than the last one he saw. It was much smaller, and he couldn't see any giants around him.

Yuan quickly noticed a figure standing in front of him. This person was a young man with long blonde hair that shone like gold under the sunlight, and he was a head shorter than Yuan, but he emanated an aura that was far superior.

Yuan ignored this person for now to look at his surroundings, and he was immediately surprised by the scenery, as he appeared to be surrounded by clouds.

'Where am I? What kind of trial is this?' Yuan wondered to himself.

Ding!

<You have started your third trial in the Stairway to Heaven>

<Defeat 'Kulas'>

<Defeat 'Kulas' three times for a special reward>

'Kulas?' Yuan raised an eyebrow upon seeing this familiar name.

After realizing the situation, he turned to look at the young man standing not far away from him.

"Giant Emperor Kulas?!"

Yuan didn't recognize him immediately because he looked much younger than the Giant Emperor Kulas from the previous trial, not to mention his size.

"Who the hell are you calling the Giant Emperor? Stop daydreaming and fight me already, Tian Yang!" Kulas shouted while pointing his fingers at Yuan.

Yuan's eyes widened with shock.

'What is going on? Why does he look human? I thought Giant Emperor Kulas was born a giant! Is this the Stairway to Heaven messing with me, or is there something I am missing here?'

Kulas spoke again, "Remember! No weapons or treasures! This is how a real man should fight— with their bare hands!"

He showed Yuan his fists and his arms that were bulging with muscle and veins.

Yuan tossed aside all his questions temporarily and held his fists in front of him.

"Here I come!" Kulas suddenly dashed towards him.

Whoosh!

Kulas swung his fist at Yuan at lightning speed.

'What?!'

The speed of Kulas' strike was so fast that Yuan could only see a blurred arm for a split second before feeling intense pain in his body, as Kulas' fist had struck him directly in his body.

When Kulas struck Yuan's body, it felt like someone had shot a cannon ball at him. If it wasn't for his perfect physique and enhanced body, Kulas' strike would've made a hole in his body.

After being struck, Yuan immediately retreated to gain some distance.

'Shit! It hurts!' Yuan nearly fell to his knees from the pain.

"What's wrong, Tian Yang? You don't look so good. I have been waiting for this moment—the day that I will finally defeat you! Ahaha!" Kulas laughed out loud.

Yuan showed a bittersweet smile, 'Even with the perfect physique, this trial won't be easy...'

"Here I come again!" Kulas warned him before rushing at him again.

'I can't react to his strikes, so I can only endure them!'

Yuan activated the Golden Mountain Body Refinement and discarded all thoughts of avoiding, only focusing on attacking back.

Whoosh!

Yuan gritted his teeth and prepared for the strike.

The moment Kulas' fist landed on his body, Yuan struck back with his own fist.

Kulas' eyes widened with surprise after feeling the strength behind Yuan's strike.

"Not bad! Let's see how long you can last!" Kulas shouted as he threw a second punch, then a third, and a fourth.

Yuan would tank all of Kulas' strikes with his bare body before retaliating with his own attack, and over the next few hours, the two of them would continue exchanging blows in such a manner, almost as though they were participating in the Tournament of Strength.

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Chapter 1036 Kulas(2)

Chapter 1036 Kulas(2)

A few hours have passed since Yuan and Kulas started battering each other relentlessly like crazy.

Even though every strike was accompanied by intense pain, there was a smile on Yuan's face.

The same goes for Kulas, who was smiling from ear to ear as their blood splattered all over the floor.

"I don't think I have the stomach to watch this..." Chu Liuxiang turned away from the pond after seeing Yuan's bloodied body.

Meixiu was also having a hard time watching Yuan suffer such brutal abuse.

However, Li Jinxi watched them with an intense gaze, almost as if she was completely absorbed in their fight. In fact, her gaze showed signs of envy.

"Despite the bloody scene, the Young Master seems to be enjoying it. In fact, he's even tempering his body with his opponent's attacks." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Didn't he already achieve a 'perfect physique' through the Perfect Tempering Ginseng? Why does he still need to temper his body?" Chu Liuxiang asked.

Xiao Hua then spoke, "Just because Brother Yuan has a perfect physique doesn't mean he has an invincible body and no longer needs to train. Having a perfect physique just means that he has the ideal body for tempering his body, allowing him to progress faster than other body refiners."

"I see..." Chu Liuxiang mumbled.

"The Young Master seems to be progressing at a rapid rate. In the beginning, his face would twist with pain every time he is struck, but his face barely moves now. He's not only gotten used to the pain, but his body is also strengthening to the point where his opponent's strikes are no longer as effective. It won't be long before the Young Master wins the fight." Feng Yuxiang explained further.

Sure enough, after exchanging blows with each other for another hour, Kulas became the first to fall to his knees.

"You're a crazy bastard, Tian Yang... No matter how many times I punch you, you won't go down, and it even seems like you're getting stronger. How is that possible?" Kulas muttered in an exhausted voice as he knelt on the ground.

"Who knows." Yuan responded with a similarly exhausted voice.

Of course, the only reason he was still standing was due to his perfect regeneration that would heal all of his internal injuries and more within moments after Kulas inflicted them.

"Anyways, this is your win." Kulas then said.

"Let's have another match." Yuan immediately said afterward.

Kulas looked at him with wide eyes.

"Nah! Forget it! I won't defeat you even if we fight a hundred times!"

Yuan was a little taken aback by Kulas' refusal.

'If he refuses to fight me, I won't get the special reward! I need to think of something quick!'

After pondering for a moment, Yuan suddenly showed Kulas a mocking smile, "You're giving up just because you lost once? What a coward. When

did you lose your spine, Kulas? If you're this pathetic, don't ever come to me for another fight!"

Kulas' eyebrows suddenly twitched.

"What the fuck did you just call me?" He glared at Yuan with intense killing intent.

Yuan continued to smile, "A coward because that's what you are."

"If you want to fight so badly, I will fight you and make you regret calling me a coward! However, give me three days! We will start our second match in three days!"

"That's what I am talking about. Let's have three matches. If you can defeat me even once, I will consider it your win." Yuan said.

"Then I will see you in three days!" Kulas stood up and limped to the small building that was located at the edge of the platform.

'Does he live here? Where is this place, anyway?' Yuan wondered to himself.

Once Kulas entered the building, Yuan sat down to cultivate.

After recovering his injuries, he began walking around the edge of the place.

'It appears that we're somewhere in the sky, but what will happen if I try to leave this place?'

In order to satisfy his curiosity, Yuan flew off the edge of the platform and into the thick clouds.

After flying straight for a few seconds, Yuan came out of the clouds and arrived at another platform.

However, this platform looked exactly the same as the previous, not to mention the building in the distance and the blood on the floor.

Yuan tried flying towards another direction, but he was still brought back to the same place.

'So I am limited to this place for this trial, huh?'

Besides the house that Kulas had entered, there was a small tree behind the building as well as a small pond that was filled with clear water.

Yuan approached the tree and the pond.

There was nothing out of the ordinary about the tree, but the pond was just deep enough to be used as a bath.

Yuan narrowed his eyes on the water. Although the water looked ordinary at glance, he could sense a faint aura coming from it.

After pondering for a moment, he placed a finger into the water.

'This water looks ordinary, but it actually contains an immense amount of spiritual energy! It's ideal for tempering one's body, too! Kulas probably gave me three days for a reason, this being the reason!'

After realizing that the water could be used to temper his body, Yuan quickly stripped naked before submerging his body inside the water that happened to fit his body perfectly, and he began tempering his body with it.

Meanwhile, in the spectators' room, the ladies' gazes were fixated on Yuan's perfect body.

"It wasn't obvious with his clothes on, but his body really underwent some major changes after consuming the Perfect Tempering Ginseng!" Chu Liuxiang could feel her mouth producing more saliva than usual after seeing Yuan's new body.

In fact, everyone there except Xiao Hua was ogling at Yuan's body at this moment, especially Li Jinxi, who appeared the most dazed out of everyone there.

When Xiao Hua noticed their odd expressions, she raised an eyebrow and asked in an innocent voice, "What's wrong with all of you? Is there something wrong with Brother Yuan?"

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Chapter 1037 Kulas(3)

Chapter 1037 Kulas(3)

"No... There's nothing wrong..." The ladies in the room responded to Xiao Hua's question with a somewhat rosy face.

Three days later, Yuan opened his eyes when Kulas came out of the building.

"What are you doing? Get out of there and fight me! I'm ready for our rematch!" Kulas said to him.

"Alright. Give me a moment." Yuan jumped out of the small pond and got dressed before going to stand in front of Kulas.

"Ready?" Kulas asked with a confident smile on his face.

'His aura has improved tremendously in just three days. I reckon that he's at least 30 percent stronger than before...' Yuan thought to himself after seeing Kulas' aura that made it seem as though the space around him was distorting.

However, it was not just Kulas who had improved over the past three days.

Yuan's physique also experienced significant improvements after tempering himself in the clear water.

"Then let's go!" Kulas suddenly stepped forward and punched his fist at Yuan.

Yuan immediately activated Golden Mountain Body Refinement and stood still, letting Kulas hit him directly in his chest.

A ripple swept the air after the impact, and Yuan could feel his muscles screaming in pain, but he endured it and retaliated with his own fist.

The way they fought each other was the exact same as before. It was more of an endurance challenge than a proper fight, but neither of them complained.

Kulas enjoyed fighting like this as it got his blood pumping with excitement. As for Yuan, he couldn't ask for a better training partner. His body would become studier, more refined, and stronger with every strike, so he had no reason to complain.

After a hundred strikes, Kulas suddenly roared, and his body grew slightly larger.

'This is!' Yuan's eyes widened with surprise after seeing Kulas' sudden transformation.

A wide smile appeared on Kulas' face as he sent his fist flying at Yuan.

Yuan, who had no intention of avoiding the strike, could feel an immense pressure coming from Kulas' fist.

"Ah!"

Yuan cried out in pain for the first time when his right arm was sent flying by Kulas' attack.

"Yuan!"

"Young Master!"

"Brother Yuan!"

The ladies in the spectators' room exclaimed when they saw Yuan's entire arm fly off his shoulder after being struck by Kulas, their faces turned pale, as they have never seen Yuan suffering such a grievous wound before except the time when he was in the Mystic Realm.

Yuan jumped back to gain some distance from Kulas, who remained standing there with a smile on his face.

He glanced at his severed arm that had fallen several meters away before turning to look at the injury on his body.

'What a powerful punch!' Yuan swallowed nervously as he blocked his injury with his spiritual energy, preventing any more blood loss.

Kulas suddenly started laughing, "Hahaha! How do you like my—"

However, before he could even finish his sentence, Yuan's Perfect Regeneration kicked in, growing him a new arm within seconds.

Kulas stared at Yuan with his eyes as wide as saucers.

"What the fuck did you just do?! How did you just—?! Are you even human?!" Kulas exclaimed in a shocked voice while pointing at Yuan.

"Of course I am human. What about you? Is that the Great Mammoth Body Refinement that I have heard about?" Yuan said with a smile on his face.

"So you already knew about this technique... That's right. I am currently using the Great Mammoth Body Refinement. It not only allows me to alter my body size, it even boosts my strength by a tremendous amount. As long as I am in this state, you won't be able to take a hit from me! I won this match, Tian Yang!"

"Keep dreaming. The match isn't decided just yet!"

Yuan rushed at Kulas after fully recovering from his injury.

After tanking Yuan's hit, Kulas swung back.

However, to his surprise, Yuan didn't avoid his attack like he'd anticipated. In fact, Yuan did the complete opposite by blocking the attack with his own fist.

"Agh!"

Yuan gritted his teeth when he felt his muscles tearing apart and all of the bones in his arm shatter, and in the midst of Kulas' shock, Yuan used his other arm to strike back.

Kulas retreated several steps afterward.

"Hahahaha! As expected of my rival! You're full of surprises, Tian Yang!" Kulas laughed like a maniac as he rushed at Yuan again.

Several hours later, Kulas knelt on the bloodied ground with a look of disbelief on his face.

"You're a freaking monster, Tian Yang..." he muttered in a low voice.

"I can say the same to you, Kulas." Yuan said with a smile on his face, but his entire body was soaked in blood, looking as if he'd just taken a dip in a bath of blood.

"It's not over yet, Tian Yang! One more match! I have a feeling that I will be able to defeat you in the next match!" Kulas glared at him with a confident gaze.

"Sure." Yuan nodded.

"Seven days! I will see you in seven days!" Kulas slowly stood back up before limping towards the building.

Once Kulas disappeared inside the building, Yuan immediately entered the pond and began cultivating.

Five days later, Yuan opened his eyes and turned to look at the building with a frown on his face.

Even though Kulas was still inside the house, his aura had grown to the point where it was leaking out of the building.

"This isn't good. At this rate, he'll definitely defeat me during our third match." Yuan sighed inwardly.

However, there was no way for him to significantly increase his strength in the next two days.

'If I want to defeat Kulas in two days, I will need to use the golden aura.'

Unfortunately, he still doesn't have the capability to use the golden aura at will.

'Looks like I will have to force it to come out...' Yuan swallowed nervously after recalling how painful it was afterward.

However, he didn't have any choice.

Thus, after mentally preparing himself, Yuan activated the nameless technique.

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Chapter 1038 Heaven's Supremacy

Chapter 1038 Heaven's Supremacy

After activating the nameless technique, a crimson aura began emerging from Yuan's body.

He took several deep breaths before increasing the intensity of the technique.

In the spectators' room, the ladies were shocked when they saw what Yuan was doing.

"W-Why is he suddenly using that technique again?! Did he already forget about the backlash he'd received the last time he tried to use it!?" Chu Liuxiang exclaimed after seeing the crimson aura around Yuan.

"Who knows... I'm afraid that only he knows what he is doing." Meixiu shook her head.

Several minutes later, the deafening voice resounded inside Yuan's head.

"HOW DARE YOU!"

Yuan coughed up a mouthful of blood after hearing this voice that shook all of his internal organs.

"You dare ignore my previous warning?! Do you have a death wish, brat!?"

Yuan gritted his teeth and tried his best to ignore the pain coming from all over his body.

"Who... Who are you?!" Yuan managed to mutter.

"I am above all that exists in this world! I am Heaven's Supremacy!"

"Argh!"

The pain was so unbearable that Yuan fell unconscious before he could ask any more questions.

"Yuan!"

The ladies in the spectators' room were left terrified by what they had just witnessed.

"H-He's not dead, is he...?" Li Jinxi asked in a trembling voice.

"That's ridiculous! He can't die like that!" Chu Liuxiang exclaimed.

"Calm down. Yuan is still alive." Lan Yingying suddenly said, and she continued, "If you look closely, you can see that he's still breathing. He's just unconscious."

"I don't get it... What is the Young Master trying to achieve by harming himself?" Feng Yuxiang stared at Yuan with a pondering expression on her face and an uneasy feeling in her heart.

"What about the trial...? There's only two days left before that man returns, right?" Meixiu asked.

"We can only hope for the Young Master to wake up." Feng Yuxiang sighed.

Several hours later, Yuan slowly opened his eyes.

"Where am I...?"

He pushed himself off the floor and looked around with a dazed face.

"That's right! Heaven's Supremacy! The golden aura responded to me! Does it have its own will? Just what is Heaven's Supremacy?" he pondered to himself as he sat on the ground.

After pondering for some time, Yuan took a deep breath and sat in the lotus position with a resolute face.

He then activated the nameless technique.

The ladies in the spectators' room were left speechless by his actions.

"Ah! What is he doing?! He's really doing this on purpose!" Chu Liuxiang exclaimed.

A few moments later, Yuan coughed up more blood, and the muscles in his body began squirming, almost as though it was alive.

"Aaaah!" Yuan released a deafening roar as a golden aura exploded from his body, consuming the crimson aura.

"Insolence! If you continue this reckless behavior, I will really kill you!" The ancient voice resounded once again.

"Lend me your power! I want to defeat Kulas!" Yuan said with much difficulty.

"Only those who are worthy can wield the Heaven's Supremacy! You are not worthy!" The voice boomed.

"If I am not worthy, then why are you in my body?! Why was I able to use your powers before?!"

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"Bullshit!" Yuan shouted.

Although it was just for a moment, Yuan felt the pain in his body lessen.

"You don't have what it takes to use my power! You are too weak! You are not worthy!"

The pain in Yuan's body suddenly skyrocketed.

"Agh!"

He collapsed for a second time.

A few hours later, Yuan woke up and repeated the same thing.

"YOU ARE NOT WORTHY!" The voice boomed inside his head several minutes later, causing him to lose consciousness for a third time.

After waking up, he challenged the Heaven's Supremacy for the fourth time, then a fifth, and a sixth time.

When he woke up for the seventh time, Yuan realized something.

'It's not as painful as before, and I am waking up much sooner now... Perhaps this is the secret to Heaven's Supremacy!'

An excited expression appeared on Yuan's face after realizing this.

'How much longer do I have until Kulas returns?'

Yuan looked around the trial, eventually noticing a timer above him in the sky.

'I have 12 hours left until Kulas returns! I must control the Heaven's Supremacy before then!'

He immediately began challenging the Heaven's Supremacy for the seventh time.

Three hours later, Yuan woke up after arguing with the ancient voice for over 15 minutes.

After being knocked down for the eighth time, Yuan realized something else.

'The reason it's getting less painful is not because I am getting used to the pain! It's because the Heaven's Supremacy is not as rebellious! Why? If I can understand why, then maybe I will...'

Yuan recalled the times he'd used Heaven's Supremacy by chance, trying his best to remember what he'd done before triggering it.

'Excitement... I was filled with excitement, and my heart burned with the desire to win! Could it be my desire to win that triggered it? No... Not my desire... My will!'

Yuan realized that he became less afraid of the Heaven's Supremacy after challenging it multiple times— that his will had increased!

It was at this moment another voice resounded inside his head.

"In order to control the Heaven's Supremacy, you must have an Indomitable Will! A Will that will never submit! A Will that will never waver! A Will that is strong enough to overturn even the Heavens!"

This voice sounded different than the ancient voice, yet it was very familiar to him— it was Tian Yang's voice.

"An indomitable will...?" A slight smile appeared on Yuan's face.

"So that's why it kept saying that I wasn't worthy... It was trying to make me waver! It was trying to mess with my will!"

Now that he knew how to deal with the Heaven's Supremacy, Yuan sat down and activated the nameless technique for the ninth time, and on his face was a tranquil expression that one would express when they receive enlightenment.

Chapter 1039 Heaven's Supremacy(2)

Chapter 1039 Heaven's Supremacy(2)

After sitting in the lotus position without moving or doing anything for several minutes, Yuan suddenly took a long and deep breath before releasing it.

He closed his eyes and activated the nameless technique.

A few moments later, the ancient voice resounded inside his head.

"You are not worthy! You are too weak!"

However, despite what the voice claimed, Yuan barely felt any pain in his body.

'My will is not strong enough to completely neglect the voice.'

Yuan thought to himself as he suddenly decided to enter the deepest part of his consciousness where his incarnations normally resided.

However, Tian Yang and the others were nowhere to be seen.

Instead, he could see the outline of a massive entity within his consciousness, and it was emanating a subtle golden aura.

Yuan remained calm as he approached this entity without fear.

"Are you the Heaven's Supremacy's true form?"

Even when he was right in front of the entity, Yuan was unable to see its true figure or appearance, almost as if it was perfectly blended into the darkness.

"You are not worthy." The ancient voice resounded again, but it was much calmer this time.

"If you truly believe that I am not worthy, then get the hell out of my body." Yuan said with a calm expression.

"..." **THIS CHAPTER IS UPDATE BY FREEWEBNOVEL. COM.**

The ancient voice became silent for a few moments before returning, "Did you not seek my power just recently?"

"A power that doesn't listen to its owner is useless, no matter how strong it is. Furthermore, I have the nameless technique. It's more than enough to replace you."

"THE AUDACITY!" READ LATEST CHAPTERS AT FREEWEBNOVEL. COM ONLY.

The ancient voice boomed, causing the void to tremble.

"I am the pinnacle of strength! I am the pinnacle of techniques! I am the pinnacle of treasures! I am the pinnacle of all that exists! I am the Heaven's Supremacy! There's nothing in this universe that can replace me, much less some trash like the nameless technique!"

Yuan smiled and said, "Once again, even if you are the strongest power in existence, you are useless to me if I cannot use you, just like a sword with its blade or a gun without any bullets."

"If you refuse to submit to me, I will toss you aside like trash! Without me, you are also useless, just like a weapon without someone to wield it! Even the sharpest sword in the world won't be able to threaten anyone if it's not used!"

"..."

Even though the ancient voice had mumbled something inaudible, Yuan could somehow tell that it was frustrated.

"You have three seconds to decide! In three seconds, I will leave this place and forever ignore your existence!"

"One!"

"Two!"

"Th—"

Yuan halted his voice when he noticed the massive figure suddenly shrinking in size until it was around the same size as him.

Once the shrinking stopped, the entity began approaching him, allowing Yuan to get a clearer view of it, and to his surprise, this entity now looked more like a bulky human. Furthermore, this entity appeared to have ten arms, five on each side.

"Who... No, what are you?" Yuan asked with a slight frown on his face.

"You will eventually remember, but until then, you can call me 'Shura'."

"Are you the Heaven's Supremacy's will?"

"The Heaven's Supremacy is merely a fragment of my power that I bestowed upon you. However, that does not mean it will listen to you. While the others have received its acknowledgement, you have yet to prove yourself worthy to wield its power."

"The others... as in my past lives?"

"That's right. Even Gods covet this power, yet you dare to threaten to toss it away. You're the first."

"I don't need a sword that cannot be used to defeat my enemies, no matter how sharp that sword may be." Yuan said.

"..."

After a moment of silence, Shura spoke, "Very well. Then I will allow you to wield the Heaven's Supremacy to show you what you'll be missing out on if you throw it away. However, you will only get three chances. If you do not receive the Heaven's Supremacy's acknowledgement after three uses, you won't be able to use it until you do."

"Don't disappoint me, brat."

Shura's figure disappeared shortly after.

However, right as Yuan prepared to leave the void, he heard footsteps approaching him from behind.

When he turned around, he could see a familiar face standing behind him.

"I see that you have finally recalled Shura. It will only be a matter of time before you recall everything." Tian Yang said with a profound smile on his face.

"What do you want?" Yuan asked him.

"I'm just here to give you some advice. If you want to remember your memories faster, you should really focus on improving your cultivation. You've been a Spirit Lord for far too long." Tian Yang said.

He then tilted his head to look up into the void.

"You should wake up now. Don't keep our friend waiting."

Outside Yuan's consciousness, Kulas stood before him with a frown on his face.

"If you don't wake up soon, I will toss you off this fucking platform!" Kulas shouted at him.

Yuan opened his eyes the following moment, his gaze emanating an otherworldly pressure.

As he slowly stood up, his body exuded a golden aura that flickered like flames, making it seem as if his body was engulfed in fire.

"W-What the hell is happening?" Kulas stared at Yuan with wide eyes, his confidence wavering.

"Are you ready for our rematch?" Yuan asked him in a calm voice.

Kulas swallowed nervously, but he still nodded his head, "Damn right I am ready!"

Kulas immediately moved into action by attacking first.

Yuan could tell that Kulas had become twice as strong as before, but his confidence and will remain unwavering.

"I-Impossible..." Kulas uttered in disbelief a second later, his movements completely frozen when Yuan caught his fist with a single hand.

"Heads up." Yuan said right before punching Kulas square in the face with his other hand.

Whoosh!

Kulas' body was sent flying the very next second, his body slamming into the building in the distance, completely destroying it.

Chapter 1040 Heaven's Supremacy(3)

Chapter 1040 Heaven's Supremacy(3)

"No way... What happened to the Young Master? Why did he suddenly acquire so much strength?" Feng Yuxiang was shocked after witnessing Yuan's prowess.

"It must have something to do with his golden aura. Everytime it appears, his prowess increases tremendously, almost like my nameless technique, but even my nameless technique couldn't hold a candle against his mysterious technique." Li Jinxi said.

A few moments after he was sent flying, Kulas dug himself out of the rubble and approached Yuan with a wide smile on his face.

"Not bad, Tian Yang... But you'll need more than that to defeat me!"

Kulas suddenly roared, and his body began growing larger and larger, eventually becoming a 50-meter tall giant.

"Let's see if you can catch my fist with your hand now, Tian Yang!" Kulas laughed out loud as he punched at Yuan.

The pressure coming from Kulas' fist was so strong that it pushed the clouds in the background many meters back.

However, Yuan remained indifferent, his gaze completely tranquil.

"A hand? I don't need a hand to stop your attack. A single finger is more than enough." Yuan spoke as he pointed his middle finger towards Kulas'

incoming fist.

BOOM!

A massive ripple swept the place when Yuan's finger collided with Kulas' fist, sweeping away all of the clouds that surrounded them and revealing its scenery that was mostly a mountain range.

"You freaking monster..."

A terrified expression was on Kulas' face when he saw the results.

Yuan had actually managed to block his fist with a single finger! And he'd done so without being pushed back even a single step!

"Heaven's Supremacy. Remember it, Kulas, because that is what defeated you." Yuan said before throwing his punch at Kulas' fist that he'd stopped.

Whoosh!

Once again, Kulas was sent flying. However, there was nothing to stop him this time, and he was sent flying off the platform.

BOOM!

The entire mountain range trembled when Kulas landed on the ground.

[you have defeated kulas and successfully cleared the third trial]

[you have defeated kulas three times for a special reward>]

A golden orb of light suddenly emerged from the pond that Yuan had tempered his body in, and it floated towards him.

After absorbing the golden orb, a flood of memories gushed inside Yuan's head.

'This is Tian Yang's memories...' Yuan closed his eyes and digested the memories.

'I see... So this is how I met Kulas...' A small smile appeared on Yuan's face as he recalled his rivalry with Kulas and how it all began.

After he finished absorbing Tian Yang's memories, Yuan turned to look at Kulas, who was still lying on the ground, seeming unconscious.

"I hope that you're still alive out there somewhere, Kulas. I still haven't fulfilled our promise, so don't you dare die yet." Yuan mumbled in a low voice.

Unfortunately, the chances of Kulas still being alive at this moment was slim to none, as it has been tens if not hundreds of millions of years since he last met Kulas, and unless they were demons or an undying Immortal who has reached the apex of cultivation, nobody could live for that long.

Yuan returned to the Stairway to Heaven shortly after he completed his third trial.

"Congratulations, Master. You have completed all of the trials for this ascension. You can now travel to the Third Heaven." Tian'er appeared before him and said.

The ladies in the spectators' room reunited with Yuan shortly after.

"Yuan! Are you okay?!" Chu Liuxiang asked him in a worried voice.

"Why wouldn't I be okay?" he smiled. **FREE WEB NOVEL. COM**

"You took a lot of beating during this trial!"

"Yes, I did, but it made me stronger— a lot stronger. The Stairway to Heaven is not just a bridge that connects the Nine Heavens— it's also a training ground."

"Anyways, now that we can enter the Third Heaven, let's go. There's a lot of work that needs to be done." Yuan then said.

"Okay." The ladies there nodded.

"Please wait a moment, Master." Tian'er suddenly stopped them.

"What's the matter?"

Tian'er created a projection in front of her and said, "The Seven Legacy Families and the Ji Family have surrounded the Stairway to Heaven. You will be ambushed if you leave through the main gate."

The situation outside the Stairway to Heaven in the Third Heaven began to materialize in the projection, showing Yuan and the others the situation outside.

Yuan frowned upon seeing the ambush.

"The survivors of the Seven Legacy Families and the Ji Family must have reported you to them. What should we do, Young Master? We can either wait for them to leave, or we can go outside and kill all of them." Feng Yuxiang asked him.

Yuan rubbed his eyes and sighed, "Do I really have to spill so much blood the moment I enter the Third Heaven? I'd rather avoid fighting if I can. Because at this rate, we'll have to kill these families over and over again as we continue to ascend."

"If Master doesn't wish for a confrontation, I can make it so that you're teleported to a random location in the Third Heaven when you exit the Stairway to Heaven. This way, you will be able to enter the Third Heaven without encountering them right away." Tian'er suddenly said.

"A random location... So we won't know where we'll end up until we appear in the Third Heaven, huh..." Yuan began pondering.

"Yes, that's the only way to enter the Third Heaven without being ambushed." Tian'er nodded.

"What do you guys think?" Yuan asked the others for their opinion.

"I also would prefer it if we can avoid fighting..." Meixiu said.

"Me too." Chu Liuxiang said.

The others agreed with Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang.

"Since there is no objection, we'll do it your way, Tian'er." Yuan said to her a moment later.

"I understand. Then I will teleport you outside now. Until next time, Master." Tian'er said with a smile on her face before sending them out of the Stairway to Heaven.

[Congratulations! Player Yuan has become the first Player to ascend to 'Third Heaven' through the Stairway to Heaven!]

[Because of Player Yuan's efforts, 'Spirit Heaven' has re-established its connection with 'Third Heaven', allowing access for all Players!]

[All Players may now enter the Stairway to Heaven and ascend to Third Heaven without any restrictions!]

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Chapter 1041 Player Massacre

Chapter 1041 Player Massacre

"L-Look! There's an announcement!" The players that noticed the announcement quickly pointed at it.

"Third Heaven is open?! And it's Player Yuan who opened it!"

The players were filled with excitement after seeing the announcement even though it hasn't been that long since Yuan connected Spirit Heaven and the Lower Heavens.

The players began talking with their friends and their groups.

"Are you going to the Third Heaven?"

"Hell no. Don't you remember what happened when this realm was opened? Everyone and their mother rushed to ascend, but they quickly realized that it was a mistake since they weren't prepared for the increased difficulty. Besides Player Yuan, I doubt there are any other players out there who are capable enough to traverse the new level."

"Yeah, and we have barely scratched the surface for this level. I'll stay here for a few more months before I even think about ascending to the next level."

"No matter how illogical it may seem to ascend, there will always be people who don't care about the consequences or are too stupid to understand their situation. A lot of people will die in the next few days."

Sure enough, when news about the Third Heaven spread online, countless people rushed to the Stairway to Heaven to ascend.

In their eyes, even if it was extremely risky, the Third Heaven will have more opportunities than Spirit Heaven, and the spiritual energy there was much more plentiful, allowing them to cultivate faster.

However, these players would soon realize what they were getting themselves into— that they were walking towards a death trap.

Meanwhile, outside the Stairway to Heaven in the Third Heaven, the Seven Legacy Families and the Ji Family were still camping outside, patiently waiting to ambush Yuan.

"It's been over a month since this Yuan entered the Stairway to Heaven. Do you think he'd failed the trials and couldn't ascend?"

"He probably died inside the Stairway to Heaven."

"I doubt it. We have people watching the Stairway to Heaven in Spirit Heaven. They would've notified us by now if he failed the trial."

The leaders of the Seven Legacy Families spoke to each other as they sat down for some spiritual tea.

Several minutes later, their bodies froze when someone shouted, "The Stairway to Heaven is opening! He's coming out!"

"Get ready! Kill him the moment he steps out of the Stairway to Heaven!" The head of the Ji Family shouted, his voice alerting everyone there.

The following moment, a group of people walked out of the Stairway to Heaven with clear excitement on their faces.

"ATTACK!"

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Boom!

Thousands of Cultivators launched their attacks at this group of ignorant players before they could even realize what was going on, and before they

knew it, they were dead.

The world shook for a moment from so many techniques going off at once.

"Did we do it? Did we kill them?"

"We did it! We killed him! We have avenged our families!" The people there celebrated when they saw the blood splatters.

However, their celebration was cut short when someone suddenly shouted, "Wait! It's not over yet! There are more people coming out of the Stairway to Heaven!"

When the cultivators saw this, they immediately stopped celebrating to attack these innocent players that had no idea what was even going on.

"Wait... Why were there so many people? The numbers don't add up." The cultivators realized this after killing the players.

But alas, they weren't given any time to think, as more players started coming out of the Stairway to Heaven.

"T-There are more of them! Attack! Kill them all!"

The cultivators stopped thinking and merely focused on attacking the players that came out of the Stairway to Heaven. It was a massacre— one that neither side understood.

Within minutes of the massacre, the players that had been killed by the cultivators started warning the others online, and the situation spread like wildfire.

[Warning! Do not ascend to the Third Heaven! You will be killed!]

[Third Heaven is a death trap!]

[I was killed the moment I entered the Third Heaven!]

Complaints from the players that had been killed flooded the online forums and pretty much the entire internet, causing widespread shock.

"Holy shit, I am so glad that I decided to wait a few days before ascending. I dodged a bullet today."

"See! I told you that it was a bad idea to ascend so quickly!"

"But why would the NPCs attack them?"

"Who knows."

"What about Player Yuan? Since he was the first one to ascend, there's a good chance that he was also killed, right?"

The players began wondering if Yuan had also been killed by the cultivators, unaware that he was responsible for their situation.

Meanwhile, back at the Stairway to Heaven.

"There's something wrong here! Why are there so many people ascending in such a short time?! What is happening?!"

"Lord Ji! I think we have made a grave mistake! We need to stop attacking immediately!" The leaders of the Seven Legacy Families said to him.

The Lord Ji of the Third Heaven also realized that something was amiss, so he demanded for the attacks to stop.

However, it was already too late, as hundreds of players have already lost their lives because of this misunderstanding.

The cultivators waited for more players to show up so that they could ask the players about Yuan, but because of their massacre, none of the players dared to ascend anymore, and it would remain like this for an entire week.

"What the fuck is going on?! What happened to Yuan?! Did we kill him or not?!" The cultivators were at a loss, and they couldn't tell if they'd killed Yuan or not due to the chaos and misunderstandings.

The Seven Legacy Families and the Ji Family held an emergency meeting afterward. In the end, they decided to leave the scene and return home for now, leaving behind some people to investigate the situation. As for their business with Yuan, since he was nowhere to be seen and they didn't know whether they had killed him or not, they decided to consider him dead until they figured things out.

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Chapter 1042 Arriving at Third Heaven

Chapter 1042 Arriving at Third Heaven

After being teleported out of the Stairway to Heaven by Tian'er, Yuan and the others found themselves somewhere in the middle of a green valley surrounded by mountains and trees.

"Looks like we have arrived safely. I was worried about the possibility of appearing in the middle of an ocean, or worse, at the bottom of one." Chu Liuxiang said as she looked around.

"Is everyone here?" Yuan looked around to make sure that nobody had strayed from the group.

Chu Liuxiang, Meixiu, Li Jinxi, Xiao Hua, Feng Yuxiang, and Li Jinxi— all six of them were there.

"Since we've been inside the Stairway to Heaven for longer than I'd anticipated, I am going to take a few days break. We'll figure out our location and where we should go afterward." Yuan said to them.

"Okay." Xiao Hua and the other two servants returned to his body before Yuan logged off with Meixiu and the others.

After logging off, the first thing Yuan noticed was Meifeng, who was cleaning his room at this moment.

"Welcome back." Meifeng said when she noticed them removing their consoles.

"I'm back." Yuan smiled.

"I can't believe that you'd actually stayed inside Cultivation Online for over a month without any breaks. Are you feeling okay?" Meifeng asked him.

"Yes, I am perfectly fine." He nodded.

And he continued, "But my stomach is not. I'm starving..."

"I'll go cook some food right now." Meifeng stopped cleaning the room and rushed to the kitchen.

"I'm going to take a shower." He said to Chu Liuxiang after Meifeng left the room.

"I'll come with you!" Chu Liuxiang said as she hopped off the bed and rushed into the bathroom.

Yuan followed her a moment later.

"Y-Yuan! Your body!" Chu Liuxiang suddenly exclaimed when she got a clearer look at his appearance after he entered the bathroom.

"My body?" Yuan looked down at his body to see that it'd become more refined and detailed. Furthermore, he noticed that he was a little taller than before.

"The Perfect Tempering Ginseng has affected your real body as well!" Chu Liuxiang said with an excited smile on her face.

"I'm not surprised, considering how powerful the treasure was." He smiled as well.

"Since it's been awhile, let me be the first to have a taste of your new body... hehe..." Chu Liuxiang suddenly said with a lustful expression on her face.

Yuan was speechless, but he didn't reject her.

After a quick shower, Chu Liuxiang pulled Yuan into the bathtub with her, where they would spend over an hour embracing each other.

Once they were both satisfied, they took another shower to wash off the sweat before leaving the bathroom and getting changed.

By the time they arrived at the dining room, Meixiu and the others were already sitting around the table.

"Welcome back, Yuan, and congratulations on passing the trial." Wang Xiuying said to him.

"Thank you."

"Yuan, there's something you should know." Meixiu suddenly said to him with a weird expression on her face.

"What happened?"

"I just heard about it, but..."

Meixiu proceeded to tell him about the player massacre that had occurred shortly after they ascended to Third Heaven.

"Seriously...?" Yuan was speechless after hearing the news. He didn't think the Seven Legacy Families and the Ji Family would attack indiscriminately.

"Hmm? Is it just me or is there something different about you, Yuan?" Wang Ming suddenly said.

"You're right... He seems a little taller than before." Wang Bingbing agreed with him.

"Yuan... Don't tell me the Perfect Tempering Ginseng had..." Meixiu swallowed nervously after the others mentioned it, as she was already used to seeing Yuan in his new body in Cultivation Online, so she didn't immediately notice.

The same went for Li Jinxi, whose mouth opened slightly after seeing his new physique.

"Long story short, I consumed a powerful treasure during the trial, and it was strong enough to affect my real body in this world as well." Yuan explained the situation to the members.

"My god... You're like a different person." Shi Lang muttered in a dazed voice.

"Well, it was a really rare treasure that only existed during the Primordial Era. There's a good chance that the treasure I consumed was the last one in existence..." Yuan said with a smile.

"Anyways, tell me more about this massacre. What is the situation now?"

"There's not much happening. The players that tried to ascend were attacked the moment they left the Stairway to Heaven. Hundreds of players died because of this incident, and the players are no longer willing to ascend for the time being." Xi Murong explained.

"That reminds me... What about you guys? I was just about to ask Meixiu before the two of you arrived. Were you guys also attacked? People online are speculating that you were also killed in the ambush." Wu Zao asked.

"No, we weren't attacked, but that's because we knew about it in advance and left the Stairway to Heaven in another way. In fact, I am the reason for the attack..." Yuan sighed.

"Huh? You're responsible for the massacre?" They all looked at him with wide eyes.

He nodded and proceeded to explain to them about his situation with the Seven Legacy Families and the massacre that had occurred right before he entered the Stairway to Heaven.

"Because of what I did to their families in Spirit Heaven, they had set up that ambush for me... I should've warned the players before I entered the

Third Heaven, but it didn't occur to me at that time." He shook his head with a guilty expression on his face.

"Well, what's done is already done. These players were being foolish to begin with— I mean, why would they ascend when they don't have the qualifications in the first place? They would've died sooner or later, anyway." Wang Ming shrugged his shoulders, unable to pity the players that had been killed.

"Probably, but they didn't deserve to be killed in such a fashion." Yuan sighed.

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Chapter 1043 Arriving at Third Heaven(2)

Chapter 1043 Arriving at Third Heaven(2)

"By the way, what happened to the players that were killed after they entered the Third Heaven? Do they get sent back to Spirit Heaven since they respawn in the last city they visited?" Chu Liuxiang suddenly asked.

"No, they get sent to the nearest city in Third Heaven." Xi Murong said.

"What are your plans now that you're in Third Heaven?" Wang Bingbing asked a moment later.

"I'm going to visit the Myriad of Techniques to see if they have any new techniques, then I am going to visit the Demon Sealing Clan, since I have some unfinished business with the Demon Sealing Pagoda." Yuan said.

He turned to look at Li Jinxi and asked, "What about you? Now that you're in Third Heaven, what are your plans? If you want, you can follow us to the Myriad of Techniques. I can get you some free techniques."

"Free techniques?"

Yuan nodded, "Yes, and since we don't know our location, it would be better for you to follow us until we arrive at a city. Who knows how powerful the magical beasts around us are."

"Alright, then I will bother you a little longer." Li Jinxi agreed to follow them.

Sometime later, Meifeng filled the table with a feast.

"You cooked all of this in just two hours...? Even ten people would have trouble cooking this much food in such a short time!" Wang Ming was shocked by Meifeng's inhuman capabilities.

However, despite the food filling the whole table, they would empty all of the plates in less than an hour with Yuan putting in the most effort, as he was the hungriest there.

Perhaps it was due to his new physique that required more energy, but Yuan didn't feel full even after eating half of the food on the table.

"How was the food?" Meifeng suddenly asked him.

"As always, it's perfect." **FREE WEB NOVEL. COM**

"Really? But you don't seem satisfied. Perhaps you're not full yet? I will make more food—"

"It's fine. I'm not full, but I don't need to be full every time I eat. As long as I don't starve, I will be fine." He stopped her.

"If you say so..."

After their meal, Yuan returned to his room and called Yu Rou to chat with her.

"Am I bothering you right now? I can call later if that's the case." Yuan asked her as he laid on the bed.

"It's okay, I needed a break anyway." Yu Rou said.

And she continued, "Congratulations, brother. I heard the news. You entered the Third Heaven, right?"

"Yes."

"Are you okay? People are saying that you were also a victim of the player massacre. Have you heard of it?" she then asked.

"I heard of it, but you don't need to worry. None of us are hurt because..." Yuan proceeded to explain the whole situation to her.

"What?! You're currently being hunted by these powerful families?! Why?!" Yu Rou was shocked to learn of this information.

"I'm not sure either, but according to the Ji Family, the Heavens want me dead." Yuan shrugged.

"The Heavens...? Is that some kind of title for someone?"

"I'm not sure either."

"What are you going to do to these people? Are you going to kill all of them?" Yu Rou suddenly asked, her voice sounding a bit worried.

"No, I won't fight them unless it's absolutely necessary. I don't want to put you guys in danger, either. They probably think I am dead right now because of the player massacre, so I'm going to travel under a new identity for now."

"Stay safe, brother. Now that I know our souls are involved, I really don't want you to hurt yourself."

"I know." FREEWEBNOVEL.COM

The two of them continued to chat with each other for another half an hour. Once the call ended, Yuan decided to get some actual sleep.

Unbeknownst to Yuan, he would not wake up for three whole days.

Three days later, Yuan woke up, feeling incredibly refreshed.

However, he was surprised to see Wang Xiuying sitting right beside him.

"Huh? What are you doing?" He asked her.

"You're finally awake! You have been sleeping for three days now, Yuan! I was just checking your condition just to make sure you're still alive."

"Three days?" Yuan's eyes widened. "I guess it's been a while since I last got some decent sleep. What about the others?"

"I told them to not worry— that you're probably just exhausted after spending so much time in Cultivation Online."

"I see... Thank you, Xiuying."

"Don't even mention it. I am the faction's nurse for a reason," she smiled.

"Anyways, now that you're awake, go let the others know that you're okay. They're all training in the field right now."

"Okay." He nodded.

After washing his face, Yuan went to the balcony and flew to the training field that was right behind their building.

The others were relieved to see that he was fine.

"Yuan, let's spar." Li Jinxi suddenly approached him.

"Sure."

Yuan started training with Li Jinxi and the others.

Over the next several days, Yuan would relax in the real world without logging into Cultivation Online. After what he'd experienced in the Stairway to Heaven, he really needed a break.

The ladies that went to the Third Heaven with him did the same, not that they could go anywhere without Yuan in Cultivation Online.

Li Jinxi would spend all of her time training her body, motivating herself with Yuan. As for Chu Liuxiang and Meixiu, besides improving their own cultivation, they would spend the rest of their time in bed with Yuan.

After an entire week had passed since Yuan ascended to the Third Heaven, they finally decided to return to Cultivation Online.

Once they were inside Cultivation Online, they picked a random direction and started flying towards that direction, hoping they would come across a city or some people to ask for directions.

After flying for almost the entire day, they finally found a group of traveling merchants for directions.

"The nearest city would be Fu Cheng City. If you continue traveling towards the south, you should reach it in an hour." The merchants said to them.

"I understand. Thank you for your help." Yuan handed them some spirit stones to show his gratitude before continuing the journey, arriving at the city about half an hour earlier than anticipated.

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Chapter 1044 Returning to the Demon Sealing Clan's Grand Library

Chapter 1044 Returning to the Demon Sealing Clan's Grand Library

After arriving at Fu Cheng City, Yuan asked the guards there if they had a Myriad of Techniques in the city.

"Sorry, but we don't. If you're looking for the Myriad of Techniques, you'll have to go to Silver Heaven City." The guard said.

"Silver Heaven City...?" Yuan's eyes widened after hearing this familiar name, as this was where Tian Cheng originated from— where he was born!

"Which direction is the Silver Heaven City?" He then asked.

"If you continue going east, you should arrive in about four days using a flying treasure." The guard pointed toward the east and said.

"Thank you."

Yuan and the others continued their journey to Silver Heaven City.

"Silver Heaven City... I believe that's the largest city in Third Heaven." Feng Yuxiang said.

"It is, and I knew it very well."

"Really? How?" Feng Yuxiang asked, her face filled with curiosity.

"Because Tian Cheng was born in that city," he said with a smile.

"Tian Cheng...? The Divine Paragon was born in Silver Heaven City?"

He nodded, "Indeed."

'Tian Cheng? Who is that?' Li Jinxi wondered inwardly after hearing this unfamiliar name, as she was the only person there who didn't know about Yuan's reincarnation.

The trip took a little over 5 days because they didn't use any flying treasures, and they took breaks.

Once they arrived at Silver Heaven City, Yuan paid the entrance fee and entered the city.

'This place feels nostalgic yet completely foreign at the same time...' Yuan looked around the city with a dazed expression on his face.

Sometime later, they arrived at the Myriad of Techniques after getting the directions.

"Go ahead and look around. If you want any techniques, just pick it. I'm going to visit the Demon Sealing Clan's Grand Library." Yuan said to Li Jinxi and the others.

"Will you be gone for long?" Li Jinxi asked him.

"I'll be gone for several hours at most."

"Okay."

While Li Jinxi and the others looked around the Myriad of Techniques, Yuan went to the Demon Sealing Clan's Grand Library.

After showing the staff member his Demon Sealing Badge, the staff allowed Yuan to traverse to the Demon Sealing Clan's Grand Library.

"It's been a while..." Yuan stared at the Demon Sealing Clan's Grand Library with a nostalgic gaze. Now that he had Tian Cheng's memories, the place looked completely different and felt much more nostalgic and natural than before.

After spending a few moments feeling nostalgic, Yuan approached the Demon Sealing Clan's Grand Library.

The place was awfully quiet, almost as though he was the only person there. Of course, there was still a guard at the entrance of the building.

"What are you doing here? The Demon Sealing Clan's Grand Library is closed." The guard said to him.

"It's still closed?" Yuan was speechless. How long do they plan on keeping the place closed? The Demon Sealing Clan's Grand Library is a popular training ground for all Demon Sealers. It would hinder their growth if they kept it closed for too long.

In fact, this is the first time the Demon Sealing Clan's Grand Library has been closed since its founding.

Yuan didn't try to argue with the guard. Instead, he retrieved the communication jade slip that he'd received from Yan Hara.

"Senior, it's Yuan. I am currently at the Demon Sealing Clan's Grand Library, and I would like to challenge the Demon Sealing Pagoda again. If you're busy, I will return at another time."

After sending the message, Yuan began waiting for a response, which didn't take too long.

About a minute later, his communication jade slip trembled, and Yan Hara's voice resounded shortly after, "I missed your voice, little founder! You want to challenge the Demon Sealing Pagoda, right? Give me an hour. I will be there as soon as I can!"

'She's as energetic as ever.' Yuan smiled after hearing her voice.

Sometime later, when the guard noticed that Yuan wasn't leaving, he spoke, "Why are you still here? Unless you're a Master Demon Sealer, you're not allowed to enter no matter how long you stand out here!"

"My mentor is coming. She's a Master Demon Sealer." Yuan said to him.

"..." The guard no longer said anything and became silent.

A little over an hour later, Yuan could see a portal appearing not far away from his location, and a beautiful woman came out of it a moment later.

Naturally, it was Yan Hara.

"Little founder!" A bright smile appeared on Yan Hara's face the moment she saw his handsome face, even jogging towards him and waving at the same time.

"It's been a while, Senior." Yuan greeted her with a smile of his own.

However, Yan Hara suddenly slowed down to a halt and proceeded to stare at him with a baffled expression on her face.

"Senior?" Yuan raised his eyebrows in a questioning manner.

"Little founder... Did something happen to you? Why do you look the same yet so different at the same time? You even grew a few inches..." Yan Hara asked as she inspected his body at a closer distance.

She suddenly grabbed his arm and inspected his muscles by squeezing it.

"Wow, your muscles are flawlessly refined! What kind of treasure did you consume?"

"Perfect Tempering Ginseng," he said with a profound smile on his face.

"...What?" Yan Hara stopped all of her movements and stared at him with a shocked look on her face.

"I'm just joking. This is the result of my training." Yuan chuckled a moment later.

"I-I thought so! You almost gave me a heart attack, little founder! After all, the Perfect Tempering Ginseng no longer exists in this world! They've been extinct for millions of years!" Yan Hara sighed afterward.

"Anyways, let's continue talking inside." She said as she approached the Grand Library.

"Greetings, Senior Yan." The guard greeted her.

"We're going to use the Demon Sealing Pagoda," she said.

"Of course." The guard opened the doors for them without any hesitation.

Yan Hara led Yuan into the building shortly after.

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Chapter 1045 Returning to the Demon Sealing Pagoda

Chapter 1045 Returning to the Demon Sealing Pagoda

After entering the Demon Sealing Clan's Grand Library, Yan Hara led Yuan to her room.

"Take a seat. I'll make some tea for us." Yan Hara said to him.

A few minutes later, she returned with a teapot and two teacups.

"So, what have you been up to lately?" She asked him after sitting down and pouring him a cup of tea.

"Thank you." Yuan sipped on the tea a couple of times before speaking, "Nothing much, really. I just ascended to the Third Heaven."

"That fast? If I recall correctly, you'd just ascended to the Second Heaven not long ago." Yan Hara said with slightly widened eyes.

"Yes, and I intend on ascending to the Fourth Heaven as soon as I finish up some business in the Third Heaven, the Demon Sealing Pagoda being one of them." He nodded.

"I see... You're moving up faster than I'd anticipated. Of course I am not complaining. The faster you arrive in the Seventh Heaven, the sooner I will get to see you." Yan Hara smiled.

"But you're already seeing me now?" Yuan raised an eyebrow.

"This place doesn't count!" She quickly said.

Sometime later, after finishing the tea, Yuan asked, "By the way, what's the situation between the Demon Sealing Clan and the Demon Sealing Grotto right now?"

Yan Hara lowered her teacup and then said with a dispirited expression, "Not good. Not good at all. In fact, it's been getting worse."

"Demon sealers from both sides would fight each other whenever they cross paths, and several demon sealers have already died from the drama. At this rate, there will be a full-blown war between the Demon Sealing Clan and the Demon Sealing Grotto."

"How foolish..." Yuan muttered in a cold voice.

"Huh?" Yan Hara looked at him with wide eyes.

"Neither side will win this war, even if one side beats the other. The true winners will be the demons that will soon return to this world."

"W-Wait a minute... What do you mean by that? The demons are already near extinction! There's no way they would return!"

"Is that what you truly believe, or is that what you want to think?" Yuan asked her in a calm voice.

"That's what I truly believe!" She said.

"Then you should change your beliefs, Senior. Although there may not be as many demons today as there were back in the days, they won't be gone anytime soon. In fact, they're most likely recovering their forces out there somewhere."

"H-How do you know all of this...?" Yan Hara asked him in a trembling voice.

Yuan smiled and said, "I will tell you the truth later— when I defeat the Demon Sealing Pagoda."

"Defeat the Demon Sealing Pagoda? You couldn't even get past the fourth floor on your last attempt, and in case you forgot, nobody has passed that floor since the Divine Paragon— not even the current leader of the Demon Sealing Clan." Yan Hara said.

"Actions speak louder than words. If you don't believe me, I will do it right now."

"Sure..."

Yan Hara and Yuan arrived at the Demon Sealing Pagoda several minutes later.

"Whenever you're ready, little founder." Yan Hara said to him.

"I'm ready now."

Sometime later, Yan Hara paid the resources to activate the Demon Sealing Pagoda.

Once the door opened, Yuan calmly walked into the building.

"Young Master, you should save your energy for the first few fights while we fight for you." Feng Yuxiang said to him. "No, I will challenge the Demon Sealing Pagoda by myself this time. I appreciate your consideration, though." Yuan said to them.

After entering the building, Tian Chenyu's voice resounded, "Welcome to the Demon Sealing Pagoda, young demon sealer. I will now tell you the rules of this place. If you break any of them, you'll automatically be removed from this place."

The voice proceeded to repeat everything that was said the last time he was here, word for word.

Once the introductions were finished, a Superior Demon appeared in the middle of the room.

"When you're prepared to start the challenge—"

"Ready." Yuan said without any hesitation.

The Superior Demon immediately sprung into action and lunged itself at Yuan.

[Swords of Eternal Torment]

A single golden sword suddenly materialized above the demon, pinning it to the ground.

"Aaaaargh!" The demon released a pained roar.

Yuan casually plunged his bare hands into the pinned demon's chest, removing its crystal.

After crushing the crystal, the demon stopped moving and disappeared.

"Congratulations, you have managed to pass the first floor in... 9 seconds. It's a new record."

"Since you have already received a reward from this floor, you will not receive any rewards for clearing this floor."

"You may proceed to the next floor whenever you are ready."

Yuan calmly made his way to the second floor.

"Welcome to the second floor. You have one hour and thirty minutes to defeat the demon."

Upon arriving at the second floor, the scenery changed, and Yuan found himself on a platform inside a coliseum with spectators, just like the last time.

"When you're prepared—"

"Ready."

The moment he started the challenge, Yuan raised the Empyrean Overlord above him.

Ding!

A gust of wind swept the arena as Yuan blocked the Demon General's invisible attack.

[Swords of Eternal Torment]

Yuan repeated what he did the last time and pinned the Demon General to the ground before destroying its crystal.

"Congratulations, you have managed to pass the second floor in... 11 seconds. It's a new record."

"Since you have already received a reward from this floor, you will not receive any rewards for clearing this floor."

"You may proceed to the next floor whenever you are ready."

On the next floor, two demons waited for him, both Demon Generals.

"When you're—"

"Ready."

After starting the fight, Yuan waited for the demons to attack him like last time, but to his surprise, they remained standing there, seemingly hesitant for some reason.

"How boring." He sighed before using Swords of Eternal Torment, pinning them both on the ground.

"Congratulations, you have managed to pass the third floor in... 20 seconds. It's a new record."

A few seconds later, Yuan made his way to the fourth floor, where he was stopped.

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Chapter 1046 Spirit King

Chapter 1046 Spirit King

"Welcome to the fourth floor. You have fifteen minutes to defeat the demon."

On the fourth floor of the Demon Sealing Pagoda that was in a lava environment, Yuan patiently waited for the gray demon to show up.

A few moments later, the gray-skinned demon with a broken horn came out of the lava and stood on the platform before Yuan.

"When you're prepared to start the challenge, say 'Ready' out loud."

Yuan didn't immediately start the fight this time. Instead, he took a few moments to silently stare at the demon.

"What's wrong? Aren't you going to say your famous line? That I am not worthy to fight you?" Yuan suddenly spoke with a calm smile on his face.

The gray demon narrowed its eyes at Yuan.

"You have grown a little stronger since I killed you." The demon responded a few seconds later, almost as though it retained its memories of their last encounter.

"Just a little stronger?" Yuan chuckled.

And he continued in a mocking tone, "That's funny, because you seem a lot weaker to me."

"..."

The gray demon's eyes flickered with killing intent, "Watch your mouth, livestock."

"Originally, I was going to just kill you as soon as possible and get to the next floor, but I have changed my mind. I'm going to beat you senseless."

"I would love to see how you're going to do that, livestock."

Yuan smiled, and he proceeded to start the challenge.

"Ready."

The second Yuan started the challenge, the gray demon disappeared from its location.

"Brother Yuan!" Xiao Hua instinctively shouted because of what happened last time.

"Are you looking down on me, demon?"

Yuan spoke in a calm voice after catching the demon's hand without turning around.

"!!!"

The demon was shocked when it realized that Yuan had caught its attack with his bare hands.

However, when it pulled back and tried to escape, the demon became even more baffled when it couldn't break out of Yuan's grasp.

Whoosh!

Yuan suddenly flung his entire arm, sending the demon into the air before slamming it back down onto the ground.

Boom!

The platform shook when the demon landed on the ground.

Yuan then crushed the demon's head with his foot.

Of course, the demon recovered from the injury within seconds.

However, Yuan's intention was just to mess with the demon and make it feel helpless, so he continued to stomp on its head while tightly holding onto the demon's hand, preventing it from running away.

A few stomps later, Yuan pinned the demon to the ground with the Sword of Eternal Torment.

"Now let's try it with pain and demon sealing aura." Yuan spoke with a cold grin on his face.

He then stomped the demon's head into the platform again, but he covered his foot with demon sealing aura this time, sealing the demon with every stomp.

"S-Stop—"

Boom!

"Damn you—"

Boom!

Once the demon was almost completely sealed, Yuan pulled the demon off the floor and had it stand right in front of him.

"You're not worthy to fight me, demon." Yuan said before shoving his arm through the demon's chest and destroying its crystal.

"Congratulations, you have managed to pass the fourth floor in... 4 minutes and 11 seconds. It's a new record."

"Here is your reward for clearing the fourth stage."

A golden orb of light appeared from within the lava and floated towards Yuan.

After absorbing the orb of light, Yuan could feel the spiritual energy in his dantian overflow and his cultivation base soaring.

His Spirit Grandmaster cultivation instantly broke through to the peak of Spirit Lord, returning him to his original cultivation. However, that wasn't the end of it, as his cultivation continued to soar.

<You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough!>

<You have met the requirements for a breakthrough>

<You have reached First Level Spirit King>

<You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough!>

<You have reached Second Level Spirit King>

<You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough!>

<You have reached Third Level Spirit King>

<You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough!>

<You have reached Fourth Level Spirit King>

Within just a few seconds, Yuan had entered the realm of Spirit King and even skyrocketed to the fourth level.

His aura also soared.

However, Yuan didn't feel any excitement even though he is now a Spirit King, as he'd experienced even higher cultivation levels as Tian Chenyu.

"Congratulations on reaching Spirit King finally, Young Master!" Feng Yuxiang and the others congratulated him.

"Thank you." He smiled as he approached the next floor.

Meanwhile, Yan Hara was patiently waiting outside.

'Considering how fast he progressed last time, he should be on the second floor now...'

"Hmm?" She suddenly raised an eyebrow when she noticed a figure standing atop the Demon Sealing Pagoda.

"D-Divine Paragon!" Yan Hara fell on her butt when she saw his handsome face.

'Why is the Divine Paragon appearing again? Did something happen inside the Demon Sealing Pagoda?'

After steeling her resolve, Yan Hara flew into the air and approached the Divine Paragon.

'He's just an illusion, so it should be fine if I took a closer look...' she thought to herself.

Once she was right in front of the Divine Paragon, Yan Hara began inspecting his appearance in closer detail.

'The more I look at him, the more he looks like the little founder.'

Unbeknownst to Yan Hara, she no longer saw the Divine Paragon in Yuan. Instead, she saw Yuan in the Divine Paragon.

'The little founder... He's definitely a descendant of the Divine Paragon...' Yan Hara is now convinced of her theory.

Upon entering the fifth floor, Yuan found himself atop a mountain and with not two, but three demons, all three emitting the aura of a Spirit King.

Each of these demons had their own unique physique. One of them was skinny while another was bulky. The third one was even round like a balloon, which surprised Yuan. Furthermore, they were all 'sort of' Demon Emperors.

Chapter 1047 Seventh Floor of the Demon Sealing Pagoda

Chapter 1047 Seventh Floor of the Demon Sealing Pagoda

"Welcome to the fifth floor. You have one hour to defeat the demons." The Divine Paragon's voice resounded.

"How many years has it been since someone made it to this floor? I don't remember..." The skinny demon suddenly muttered as it stared at Yuan with an excited smile on its face.

However, Yuan ignored the skinny demon and focused his gaze on the fat demon.

"It's rare to see a fat demon even back in the Primordial Era. I remember my first experience with one. I nearly laughed my ass off." Yuan said with a smile on his face.

"..."

The fat demon trembled when it heard Yuan's words.

"What did you just call me, lowly livestock?" The fat demon growled in a cold voice.

Yuan laughed out loud, "Your reaction is the same as that fat demon when I laughed at it! I see... So I had decided to put you in this Demon Sealing Pagoda..."

"DIE! LIVESTOCK!"

The fat demon suddenly lunged at Yuan.

However, Yuan didn't start the challenge yet. This is the first time the demon initiated the fight.

[Demon Sealing Zone]

Yuan snapped his fingers, surrounding himself and the fat demon with the Demon Sealing Zone.

The fat demon immediately felt its strength drained by the Demon Sealing Zone.

Whoosh!

Yuan swung his sword at the fat demon while it was still in the air, slicing its body horizontally in half.

[Sword of Eternal Torment]

Yuan pinned the fat demon into the ground while its body was still severed.

"Argh! What is this feeling?!" The fat demon screamed when it experienced pain for the first time.

"This feeling is called pain. Remember it well." Yuan looked down at it with a cold smile on his face.

"How dare you look down on us!"

The other two demons shouted as it attacked the Demon Sealing Zone.

However, they quickly realized how durable the Demon Sealing Zone was, and they couldn't even put a slight crack in it.

"Coward! Fight us if you dare!"

Yuan looked at the skinny demon who just spoke and said, "You want to fight? Sure."

He removed the Demon Sealing Zone, allowing the two demons to reach him.

[Sword of Eternal Torment]

"Ah!"

The demons kneeled on the ground when multiple golden swords stabbed their back.

Yuan sighed, "Compared to before, the Demon Sealing Pagoda is too easy now."

He killed the skinny and bulky demons shortly after, leaving the fat demon for last.

"You may be laughing now, but once you reach the next floor... You will witness true horror!" The fat demon said its last words before Yuan killed it.

"Congratulations, you have managed to pass the fifth floor in... 2 minutes and 11 seconds. It's a new record."

"Here is your reward for clearing the fifth stage."

After absorbing the reward, Yuan's cultivation soared once again.

<You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough!>

<You have reached Fifth Level Spirit King>

<You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough!>

<You have reached Sixth Level Spirit King>

<You have absorbed enough Qi for a breakthrough!>

<You have reached Seventh Level Spirit King>

Yuan approached the sixth floor as a Seventh Level Spirit King.

Even before he stepped onto the sixth floor of the Demon Sealing Pagoda, Yuan noticed a massive round figure sitting in what appeared to be a sea of blood.

This round figure was the size of a mountain, and it had a hideous face that would make even the coldest warriors run away in fear.

"The Abomination, huh? No matter how many times I see it, it makes my skin crawl."

"Welcome to the sixth floor. You have five minutes to defeat the demon."

"When you're prepared to start the challenge, say 'Ready' out loud."

'Five minutes, huh?'

The purpose of the sixth floor was to test the strength of a demon sealer's demon sealing aura, hence why there was an Abomination and such a short time limit.

If one's demon sealing aura isn't strong enough, they wouldn't be able to defeat the Abomination even if they were given a hundred hours.

However, if one's demon sealing aura was strong enough, they could do so in less than five minutes.

Yuan closed his eyes and took a deep breath.

"Ready."

[Swords of Eternal Torment]

Yuan opened his eyes and summoned over a hundred golden swords to attack the Abomination, waking it up from its slumber.

He then began gathering spiritual energy for a Heaven Splitting Sword Strike as the Abomination stumbled around and screamed in pain.

After spending a whole minute gathering spiritual energy, Yuan released the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike.

With his limiter removed, the sword light from the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike was powerful enough to cover the entire Abomination's figure, and since he'd infused the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike with his demon sealing aura, the Abomination was not able to recover fast enough and was disaggregated until there was nothing left.

"Congratulations, you have managed to pass the sixth floor in... 1 minutes and 9 seconds. It's a new record."

After absorbing the reward, Yuan's cultivation soared to the peak of Spirit King.

"Looks like you'll be a Spirit Emperor in no time, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang said to him as he took a moment to recover his spent spiritual energy.

"No, I won't reach Spirit Emperor." Yuan said.

"Huh? Are you saying that you won't clear the next floor?" she asked in a puzzled tone.

"No, that's not it. You'll find out when I clear the next floor."

Sometime later, he made his way to the seventh floor.

The seventh floor of the Demon Sealing Pagoda looked completely different from the previous six floors.

There was neither a visible platform nor a sky. Instead, he was surrounded by nothing but stars, almost as though he was now inside the Stairway to Heaven.

Yuan walked onto the invisible platform and approached the figure standing many meters away. This figure had its eyes closed, seemingly asleep, but it was also emanating a bloodthirsty aura.

Yuan knew at a glance that, unlike the gray demons on the fourth and fifth floor, this demon was a full-fledged Demon Emperor.

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Chapter 1048 Fighting the Demon Emperor

Chapter 1048 Fighting the Demon Emperor

"Welcome to the seventh floor. You have 4 hours to defeat the demon."

Shortly after Yuan arrived on the seventh floor of the Demon Sealing Pagoda, the Demon Emperor, still with its eyes closed, spoke in a calm voice, "What is your name, human?"

"Tian Chenyu." Yuan said with a smile on his face to see how the Demon Emperor would react.

"..."

The Demon Emperor's eyebrows slightly twitched upon hearing Yuan's words, but other than that, it really didn't have any reaction.

"I'm just joking. You can call me Yuan, Demon Emperor."

"You're a peculiar human, Yuan. Not only are you able to stand there and talk with me without pissing your pants but you can even make jokes. I guess you made it this far for a reason."

"Oh? A demon is actually praising a human? As expected, Demon Emperors are different. Compared to the mentally weak demons that will become enraged at the slightest provocation, you guys aren't like that, and it's almost like I am speaking to another human..." Yuan said with a profound smile on his face.

"...What did you just say?" The Demon Emperor mumbled in a dazed voice, its aura suddenly shooting into the cloudless sky.

"Oh? Did I hit a nerve?" Yuan chuckled.

"Did you just compare me... to humans? You think I am like a human? Me? A Demon Emperor? Know your place!"

The Demon Emperor suddenly opened its eyes, revealing violet eyes that emanated intense killing intent.

"..."

A nervous smile appeared on Yuan's face when the Demon Emperor's chilling aura permeated the entire area there. Even with his prowess and talents, he still couldn't help but tremble before it. Although he didn't think that he was going to lose to this Demon Emperor, he knew that it wasn't going to be an easy task, especially considering that he'd just angered the Demon Emperor.

The Demon Emperor began approaching Yuan in slow and steady steps, looking extremely menacing.

Yuan tightly held onto his Empyrean Overlord and prepared to fight the Demon Emperor.

"Remember the name of the demon who will kill you, my name— Demon Emperor Wraith!"

Demon Emperor Wraith roared right before it summoned a bloody axe in both hands and rushed at Yuan.

Ding!

Yuan blocked one of its axes with the Empyrean Overlord, but the Demon Emperor had a second one, and it used it to attack him almost instantly afterward.

Ding!

The Starry Abyss appeared right in front of the location that the axe was going to land, blocking it.

However, since he was controlling the Starry Abyss with a technique, it wasn't as powerful as the sword in his hand.

Yuan quickly used his movement technique to dodge the Demon Emperor's second axe right before it bypassed the Starry Abyss' defense and gained some distance between them.

"Not bad..." Yuan smiled.

"Ha!" The Demon Emperor didn't give Yuan any time to rest and immediately chased after him.

The two of them would go back and forth for the next five minutes blocking and attacking each other.

[Swords of Eternal Torment]

A minute into their fight, Yuan summoned the golden swords.

The golden swords struck the Demon Emperor because it had appeared so suddenly. However, the Demon Emperor didn't show much reaction to it besides having an annoyed look on its face.

"So you know this pesky technique as well, huh? Although it's extremely effective against lower ranking demons, it's ineffective against Demon Emperors such as us!"

Yuan narrowed his eyes on the Demon Emperor.

'That's a bluff. The Swords of Eternal Torment definitely works on even Demon Emperors. It's just that my demon sealing aura isn't strong enough to affect it...'

[Demon Sealing Zone]

He proceeded to create a massive zone that covered almost 100 meters in radius around him and the Demon Emperor.

The Demon Emperor could feel its strength decreasing, but it wasn't by too much, and it wasn't nearly enough to make it panic.

"Another annoying technique. Hey! I thought only the Divine Paragon could use these techniques! How come you can use them as well?" The Demon Emperor suddenly asked Yuan.

"I already told you. I am Tian Chenyu." Yuan said with a smile.

'I won't be able to defeat it at this rate. I didn't want to use this because it's very risky and energy consuming, but if I want to defeat this Demon Emperor, I am going to have to use it...' He thought to himself.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan suddenly retrieved his Empyrean Overlord and Starry Abyss, becoming barehanded. His actions greatly puzzled the Demon Emperor and piqued its interest at the same time.

"What are you doing? Are you giving up already?" The Demon Emperor asked him.

"Give up? Before a demon? Over my dead body." Yuan smiled in response.

He then made some gestures with his hands before shouting out loud, "Close!"

The Demon Sealing Zone suddenly closed in on the Demon Emperor until it was basically trying to squeeze it to death.

The Demon Emperor laughed when it saw what he was doing, "What nonsense do you think you're doing?! This won't have any effect on me!"

However, before the demon could try to break out of the Demon Sealing Zone, Yuan made a few more hand gestures before shouting again, "Restrict!"

Golden chains suddenly came out of the ground and coiled itself all around the Demon Emperor's body, restricting its movements.

"How dare you underestimate me with this shit!" The Demon Emperor quickly started struggling, but it was having a little trouble breaking out of the chains, as it kept coming out of the ground and replacing the ones it broke.

'Now that I have bought myself some time...'

Yuan immediately sat on the floor and began cultivating with his eyes closed.

An unfathomable aura suddenly began emitting from Yuan's body, quickly permeating the area.

The Demon Emperor had an uneasy feeling in its guts after seeing Yuan and his aura, and it became desperate.

A few more moments later, right as the Demon Emperor broke out of the last chain, Yuan opened his eyes and shouted, "Demon Sealing Pagoda!"

The Demon Emperor's eyes widened with shock as it looked up to see that a massive golden pagoda had appeared above it.

"W-Wait!"

The Demon Emperor pleaded.

However, Yuan ignored the demon and gestured for the pagoda to fall.

The golden pagoda fell the following moment, crushing the Demon Emperor into the ground.

Chapter 1049 The True Purpose of the Demon Sealing Pagoda

Chapter 1049 The True Purpose of the Demon Sealing Pagoda

DONG!

The moment the golden pagoda landed on the Demon Emperor, a profound ripple permeated the world there, causing it to shake.

However, the Demon Sealing Pagoda wasn't meant to kill the Demon Emperor.

"LET ME OUT!" The Demon Emperor's voice boomed from within the golden pagoda.

Yuan ignored the Demon Emperor's voice and continued to focus on the golden pagoda, pouring his spiritual energy and demon sealing aura into it.

Within the Demon Sealing Pagoda, the Demon Emperor was trying its best to fight back against the demon sealing aura that was entering its body without any resistance.

The Demon Emperor knew that even with its strong resistance against demon sealing aura that it wouldn't be able to last long inside the Demon Sealing Pagoda, one of the Divine Paragon's strongest demon sealing techniques.

However, maintaining the Demon Sealing Pagoda wasn't an easy task for Yuan, who was severely lacking in cultivation.

The only reason he could use this technique at his current level is because of his memories as the Divine Paragon and his experience.

Dong! Dong! Dong!

Over the next several moments, the Demon Emperor would try to break out of the Demon Sealing Pagoda but to no avail.

Feeling like a trapped mouse, the Demon Emperor unleashed its limit and strongest technique.

However, before the Demon Emperor could fully unleash its attack, Yuan suddenly made more hand gestures and shouted, "Seal!"

"Ah!"

The Demon Emperor suddenly felt intense pain coming from all over its body, and when it looked down, it noticed many tiny needles piercing into its body.

Before the Demon Emperor could react, Yuan's voice resounded again, "Seal!"

An intense pressure infused with demon sealing aura suddenly flattened the Demon Emperor.

"Seal!"

Golden chains appeared from within the pagoda and chained the Demon Emperor.

"Seal!"

Three flags appeared the next moment and surrounded the Demon Emperor.

By now, half of the Demon Emperor's body had turned into stone, but Yuan wasn't finished just yet.

"Seal!"

"Seal!"

"Seal!"

Yuan repeated the word nine times in total.

After the ninth 'seal', the Demon Emperor was completely sealed.

Yuan deactivated the Demon Sealing Pagoda immediately afterward and began to recover his cultivation.

Half an hour later, after recovering enough spiritual energy, Yuan began charging up for a maximum power Heaven Splitting Sword Strike to finish off the Demon Emperor once and for all.

And just to make sure the Demon Emperor was as weak as possible, he surrounded the Demon Emperor with the Demon Sealing Zone to further increase his chances of killing it in one go.

Once he was prepared, Yuan released his strongest Heaven Splitting Sword Strike yet.

The Heaven Splitting Sword Strike was so powerful that it caused the space there to distort.

A few moments later.

"Congratulations, you have managed to pass the seventh floor in... 1 hour, 20 minutes, and 37 seconds. It's a new record."

"Here is your reward for clearing the seventh stage."

A golden orb of light floated towards Yuan, but it wasn't something he could absorb.

The golden orb of light disappeared once it reached Yuan, turning into a small golden ring.

Yuan smiled when he saw this ring. He accepted it and tossed it into his spatial ring without even inspecting it, almost as though he already knew what it was and what it was capable of.

"What was that ring, Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang asked out of curiosity as he approached the eighth floor.

"Something that I will need in the future," he said.

"Eh?! Don't keep us in suspense, Young Master!"

Yuan merely kept on smiling, refusing to tell them about it.

Upon arriving at the 8th floor, Yuan found himself in the middle of an ocean with no land, but there were also no signs of a demon.

"Welcome to the eighth floor."

The Divine Paragon's voice resounded, but he didn't say anything about the clear condition.

Despite that, Yuan remained calm.

"What is going on, Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang asked him.

"You will see in a few minutes." He said.

He then sat down and started cultivating to recover his spent spiritual energy from the previous fight.

Fifteen minutes later, Yuan stood up and turned to look towards the east before flying in that direction.

Half an hour later, Yuan stopped when he arrived before a small island.

After landing on this island, he looked around until he found a jade tablet that was located in the center of this island.

He approached it before giving it a good kick, shattering the jade tablet.

"Congratulations, you have managed to pass the eighth floor in... 33 minutes and 20 seconds."

"Here is your reward for clearing the eighth stage."

"Huh?! What?! What just happened?!" Feng Yuxiang exclaimed while shocked and puzzled at the same time.

Xiao Hua and Lan Yingying felt the same, as they couldn't comprehend what had just happened.

Yuan didn't say anything until after he accepted the reward, which was even more puzzling than the 8th floor itself.

"A scabbard for a sword...?" Xiao Hua mumbled.

"I will be needing this very soon," he said.

"Anyways, the eighth trial is a special one. Unless you know where to go and what to do, it's impossible to clear this floor."

"What...? That means..."

"Indeed. Unless that person has the Divine Paragon's memories or is the Divine Paragon himself, it is literally impossible to pass the eighth floor." Yuan said with a smile.

"What if someone found the tablet by chance?" Feng Yuxiang suddenly asked.

"They still wouldn't be able to destroy it because you need to hit it with a precise amount of demon sealing aura. It won't budge even if you're slightly off."

"Isn't that a little... cheating?"

Yuan chuckled, "The true purpose of the Demon Sealing Pagoda isn't to train demon sealers. You'll understand soon."

Sometime later, Yuan began ascending the final staircase to reach the ninth floor of the Demon Sealing Pagoda.

"T-This place is..." Feng Yuxiang muttered in a dazed voice after seeing the ninth floor for the first time.

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Chapter 1050 Ninth Floor of the Demon Sealing Pagoda

Chapter 1050 Ninth Floor of the Demon Sealing Pagoda

"Welcome to the ninth floor of the Demon Sealing Pagoda and my little secret place. The three of you are the first ones besides Tian Chenyu to see this place." Yuan said to them with a smile.

Feng Yuxiang and the others came out of his body to look at the scenery before them.

"What is this place?" Lan Yingying asked him.

They were standing before a small hill that was filled with flowers, and on the top of this hill was a large tree. However, this place didn't look anything special. In fact, it looked oddly ordinary.

Despite that, this place was one of the most important and precious places in Tian Chenyu's memories.

"Tian Chen—I used to come to this place often with my childhood sweetheart before she was killed by a demon, though it was always against my own will." Yuan said with a bittersweet smile on his face.

"And this place is the true purpose of the Demon Sealing Pagoda? I still don't understand." Feng Yuxiang asked.

"Just wait a little longer." Yuan said.

He then raised his arm and pointed it at the tree before making a beckoning motion with his hand.

Whoosh!

A long object suddenly flew from the tree and into the air for a few seconds before it pointed itself at Yuan and flew towards him.

"Young Master! Watch out!" Feng Yuxiang warned him.

"It's fine." Yuan said with a calm look on his face before catching this object in one smooth motion.

"That is... a sword?" Xiao Hua mumbled.

Yuan nodded as he held the black and red sword in front of him to show it to the others.

Unlike the Empyrean Overlord that was classified as a Greatsword, this sword with a black hilt and a thin red blade was shaped like most ordinary swords. However, this sword was anything but ordinary, as it naturally emitted a demon sealing aura that was strong enough to rival even the top demon sealers in the Demon Sealing Clan. Furthermore, if one looked closely, they would be able to see the words 'Demon Sealing' flawlessly engraved on both sides of the blade.

"Demon Sealing Sword— this is one of the Divine Paragon's three demon sealing treasures that he used to push the demons to near extinction."

"And this scabbard from the last stage is from this sword." Yuan placed the sword back into its scabbard, reuniting the two after millions of years of being apart.

"Why did you separate it in the first place? And why make the scabbard the reward for the eighth floor?" Lan Yingying couldn't help but ask.

Yuan smiled and said, "This may seem like a joke, but I am serious when I say this. I made it the eighth floor's reward because I couldn't be bothered to find a proper reward. After all, nobody besides myself would be able to pass the eighth floor, so there's no point in putting any treasure there."

"Unbelievable..." Feng Yuxiang mumbled.

"Anyways, now that I have this sword, all demons will be at my mercy."
Yuan said with a cold grin on his face as he stared at the sword in his grasp.

[Demon Sealing Sword]

[Grade: Mythic]

[Quality: Peak]

[Description: Once wielded by the Divine Paragon and used to slay over 100,000 demons. Demons damaged by this sword will instantly be sealed. Damage inflicted with this sword increased by 1,000%.]

The girls swallowed nervously when they saw his face.

"Even without the sword, you wouldn't lose to any demons..." Feng Yuxiang said.

"That's not true. In my current state, I would lose if I encountered a real Demon Emperor. In the end, the Demon Emperor from the seventh floor isn't a real Demon Emperor, else it wouldn't have lost so easily." Yuan shrugged.

"Anyways, now that we are done here, let's get out." He then said.

They nodded and returned inside his body.

Before leaving the Demon Sealing Pagoda, Yuan took a moment to gaze at the scenery one last time.

"We will definitely reunite again, Ai Rong..." Yuan mumbled in a low voice before disappearing from the ninth floor, appearing back on the first floor a moment later.

After storing the Demon Sealing Sword inside his spatial ring, Yuan approached the exit and opened the door, leaving the Demon Sealing Pagoda.

Outside the pagoda was Yan Hara, who had a surprised look on her face for some reason.

"You're out already? What happened? You were inside for a much shorter time than your first attempt!" She asked him.

"Yes, and I cleared the Demon Sealing Pagoda." Yuan said with a calm face.

"Y-You what...?" Yan Hara stared at him with a baffled look on her face.

"I cleared it. On the fifth floor, I had to fight three demons that were all at the same level as the demon on the fourth floor. On the sixth floor, I had to fight an Abomination. On the seventh floor, I had to fight a real Demon Emperor. I didn't have to fight anything for the last two floors because there was nothing to fight." Yuan gave her a brief explanation about his experience inside the Demon Sealing Pagoda.

"Three demons? An Abomination? A real Demon Emperor?" Yan Hara still couldn't believe it. Did Yuan really manage to clear the Demon Sealing Pagoda that hasn't been cleared since its creation in just a few short hours?

"Anyways, there's something I want to talk to you about, Senior Yan... Or should I call you Demon Sealer Yan? This is a very important topic that concerns the future of the Demon Sealing Clan."

"W-What are you talking about?" Still dazed, Yan Hara asked him.

In response, Yuan retrieved the ring he'd acquired from the seventh floor of the Demon Sealing Pagoda as a reward and showed it to her.

"Do you know what this is?" He asked her.

Yan Hara's eyes widened with shock when she saw the ring.

"I-I-Impossible! Why do you have that ring?!" Yan Hara was so shocked that she fell on her buttocks.

Yuan smiled and said, "Let's go somewhere more private."

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Chapter 1051 Demon Sealing Ring

Chapter 1051 Demon Sealing Ring

"You! That ring! Why?!" Yan Hara quickly got back to her feet and grabbed his hand to take a closer look at the ring, but she didn't dare to touch the ring with her own hands.

"I-Is this real? If this is fake, you must destroy it immediately! If the Leader of the Demon Sealing Clan or the Grand Elders find out that you have something like this, they will give you a public execution!"

"Don't worry, it's real." Yuan said as he put the ring back into his spatial ring.

"Let's go somewhere more private, shall we?"

Yan Hara nodded with a serious look on her face.

Sometime later, Yan Hara locked the both of them inside one of the study rooms in the Grand Library. This specific room was only accessible to Master Demon Sealers and above because it contained high-ranking demon sealing techniques, and it only allowed a limited number of people inside at once—two people exactly, so it was safe.

"Tell me, little founder! Where did you acquire that ring?! Do you have any idea what that ring signifies?!" Yan Hara asked him in a nervous voice.

"Of course I do. It's the Demon Sealing Ring, and only the leader of the Demon Sealer Clan can hold this ring." Yuan said in a calm voice.

Indeed, the ring he'd acquired from the Demon Sealing Pagoda was none other than the Demon Sealing Ring from when he was still the leader of the

Demon Sealing Clan. It was a precious item with a significant amount of history as well as importance behind it.

"But how...? There should only be one in existence, and the current leader of the Demon Sealing Clan has it..." Yan Hara mumbled in a dazed voice.

"Qian Chu? He has the spare one I gave to the Demon Sealing Clan before I disappeared. The one I have is the original." Yuan casually said.

"Excuse me...? Before you disappeared? Who are you really, little founder?"

Yuan smiled and said, "You still don't recognize me?"

He found it quite humorous that Yan Hara still couldn't recognize his identity despite being his biggest fan.

"Then how about this?"

Yuan suddenly activated the Demon Sealing Zone around them.

"The Demon Sealing Zone?! When did you learn this technique?!"

"I'm not done yet."

[Swords of Eternal Torment!]

He created the golden swords in the air.

"I lied when I said this wasn't the Sword of Eternal Torment. Indeed, this is the lost technique of the Demon Sealing Clan— Sword of Eternal Torment."

Yan Hara stared at these dazzling techniques before her with wide eyes and a gawking look on her pretty face.

"Y-You... You can't be... No..." Although Yan Hara had an idea about his true identity, she didn't dare to believe it.

"Still not enough to convince you? Then how about this beauty?" Yuan retrieved the Demon Sealing Sword and showed it to her.

"That's—!" Yan Hara could feel her heart beating at her chest when she saw the beautiful sword.

Although she's never personally seen it before, she has heard stories and read about it before. This chapter is updated by FreeWebnOvel.com.

A red blade with the words 'Demon Sealing' engraved on it—

"Demon Sealing Sword... One of three demon sealing treasures wielded by the Divine Paragon..." Yan Hara muttered in a dazed voice.

Yuan then spoke in a calm voice, "Tian Chenyu— although this name had been lost with the passage of time for most people, I have one more identity that you should be familiar with—"

"Divine Paragon..." Yan Hara suddenly muttered out loud in a trembling voice, her eyes flowing with tears.

"Is it really you?"

Despite her powerful cultivation, Yan Hara felt so weak at this moment that she couldn't even stand up, so she fell to her knees.

"Yes, it's really me. Although I am now called Yuan, I used to be the Divine Paragon."

Although what Yuan said sounded unbelievable and borderline impossible, Yan Hara did not doubt him at all, as she had already been suspicious of his true identity for a while now.

After a moment of silence, Yan Hara bowed her head until her forehead kissed the cold marble floor, and she spoke in a revering voice, "This junior greets Senior. Welcome back to the Demon Sealing Clan, Founder."

"Stand up, Yan Hara. I revealed my identity to you because I consider you a friend and I trust you."

"I apologize, but I won't be able to stand up for a while..." Yan Hara said in an embarrassed voice.

Yuan smiled and helped her up before carrying her to a nearby chair.

"T-Thank you... Senior..." Yan Hara said with a flushed face, looking like a young maiden before her crush.

"Drop the formalities and continue calling me Yuan—or little founder. Either works. I also need to keep my identity a secret." Yuan chuckled.

"I understand... little founder." Yan Hara nodded.

Sometime later, once Yan Hara had calmed down enough, she asked, "If you don't mind me asking, why did you suddenly disappear for millions of years, little founder? And why did you decide to come back now?"

Yuan smiled and said, "I didn't disappear. I died and reincarnated. I recently recalled my memories as the Divine Paragon, so here I am."

"You died...? How is that possible? Did a demon do it?"

What came out of Yuan's mouth next nearly knocked Yan Hara unconscious with shock.

"Nope, I killed myself." Yuan casually uttered.

"S-Suicide?! But why in heaven's name would you do something like that?!"

"I have my reasons. Sorry for the inconvenience it caused, but it was an absolutely necessary thing for me to do."

"I don't dare to judge your decisions. If you did it, I'm sure it was for a good reason." Yan Hara said with a bittersweet smile.

"Anyways, I didn't plan on returning to the Demon Sealing Clan initially even though my memories had returned because I didn't want to mess up whatever you guys had going on, but with the situation between the Demon

Sealing Clan and the Demon Sealing Grotto growing more dire, it seems I have no choice but to return since I cannot sit by and watch fellow demon sealers destroy each other when you should be fighting demons instead."

"On the behalf of all of the demon sealers out there, I'm truly sorry... We have failed you and stained the Demon Sealing Clan's prestigious name..." Yan Hara sighed with her head lowered, not daring to look at Yuan's face due to shame.

"Although the situation is pretty dire, it's not at the point of no return. We can still salvage the situation and put a stop to the fight." Yuan said.

"What do you have in mind?"

"First and foremost, we will need to get rid of Qian Chu. I don't know what he's up to, but it's not good— at least that's what my instincts are telling me. The Demon Sealing Clan— my Demon Sealing Clan will collapse at this rate, and I am not going to sit still and watch a place that I'd built with my own hands being destroyed." Yuan spoke with a cold expression on his face, causing Yan Hara to tremble.

Chapter 1052 Divine Paragon's Legacy

Chapter 1052 Divine Paragon's Legacy

"It's not going to be easy removing Qian Chu from his position, unless you plan on using your identity to suppress him..." Yan Hara said with a worried look on her face.

"I intend on using my identity. However, I will only do so after we have enough support on our side. Therefore, we need to focus on finding people we can trust and get them on our side, so when it comes time to fight Qian Chu, it won't just be the two of us. I will leave this task to you."

"W-What?! You want to leave such an important task to me?! I-I don't think I am ready for it!" Yan Hara exclaimed in a terrified voice.

"If you cannot do it, nobody else can. First and foremost, you're already a respected and well-known Demon Sealer within the Demon Sealing Clan. You also have a lot of experience in the Demon Sealing Clan— even more than me since this place is no longer the Demon Sealing Clan that I once knew, so my experience might as well be thrown aside."

"Furthermore, as a Master Demon Sealer, you should have connections to many high-ranking Demon Sealers. I want you to bring those that are trustworthy to our side."

Yan Hara swallowed nervously, "I'm afraid of bringing someone unworthy and putting our whole secret at risk..."

"I trust in your judgment." Yuan smiled.

After a moment of silence, Yan Hara spoke in a defeated manner, "If you really think I have what it takes, I will do my best."

'Not that I could ever refuse the founder of the Demon Sealing Clan...' she sighed inwardly.

"That's what I like to hear. Of course, I won't just tell you to do all of this for free. In return for helping me, I will make you the strongest Demon Sealer in the whole Demon Sealing Clan and the Demon Sealing Grotto."

"I-I don't need any payment! I will gladly assist you even if I don't get anything in return— not that I expected anything in the first place!" Yan Hara quickly shook her head.

"Nonsense. You're my friend and trusted aid, it's only natural that I assist you in my own way, and as the founder of the Demon Sealing Clan, there is only one thing that I can offer you— guidance."

"Give me your forehead." Yuan suddenly beckoned her.

"Yes..."

Not knowing what to expect, Yan Hara leaned her head forward.

After a moment of silence, Yuan suddenly tapped her forehead with his finger that was emanating a glowing light.

A multitude of information of demon sealing techniques that had been lost with the passage of time along with demon sealing techniques that Tian Chenyu never shared quickly flowed inside Yan Hara's mind.

Yan Hara sat there with a blank expression on her face as she absorbed all of this shocking information.

Many minutes later, she snapped out of her daze and stared at Yuan with a shocked look on her face, her body trembling from excitement and many other emotions.

"I am officially making you my successor—the first Demon Sealer to become successor to the Divine Paragon's legacy. Are you willing to accept this role?" Yuan asked her with a smile on his face.

"..."

Yan Hara's jaw dropped to the ground after hearing his words.

After a moment of silence, she spoke in a low voice, "You're asking me that after giving me so much priceless demon sealing techniques...?"

She didn't know whether to laugh or cry, so she did both at once.

"That's how much I trust you." Yuan chuckled.

Sometime later, Yan Hara got off her chair and kneeled before Yuan before kissing the floor with her forehead.

She spoke in a kowtowing position, "This unworthy junior will humbly accept this esteemed role as your successor."

Yuan nodded, "When the time is right, I will teach you the rest of the demon sealing techniques, including the ultimate demon sealing technique that I have only used once. I would teach you the Swords of Eternal Torment as well as other demon sealing techniques that only I know, but I don't want you to make yourself a target for Qian Chu. He will definitely go after those techniques."

"Once you are strong enough and with enough backing, I will teach the rest of them to you."

"I am already more than satisfied with the demon sealing techniques you have given me." Yan Hara said.

"Anyways, let's talk more about the situation with the Demon Sealing Clan and the Demon Sealing Grotto. I also know very little about the latter. Tell me everything you know about them." Yuan said a moment later.

"Okay."

Over the next several hours, Yan Hara would talk about the whole situation in detail as well as answering any questions that Yuan had for her.

Once all that was done, Yuan prepared to leave the Demon Sealing Clan's Grand Library to return to the Myriad of Techniques.

"Do you have anything you want to tell me before I leave?" Yuan asked her.

Yan Hara pondered for a moment before speaking with a bashful smile on her face, "This may sound cliché, but I want to thank you for not abandoning the Demon Sealing Clan and returning to us. According to the rumors out there, they say that you never really cared about the Demon Sealing Clan."

Yuan chuckled, "The rumors are true. I never really cared for the Demon Sealing Clan at first because it was created randomly. In fact, I wasn't the one who came up with the idea of creating the Demon Sealing Clan. One of my followers came up with this suggestion as a joke— one that people took seriously, and before I was aware, the Demon Sealing Clan had come into existence. The rest is history."

"Seriously...?" Yan Hara was baffled after learning this shocking information.

To think that the glorious Demon Sealing Clan had started as a joke, who knows how the Demon Sealers would react if they learned of this information.

"Anyways, I will come back here once in a while to hear about your progress. Until then." Yuan waved goodbye to Yan Hara before disappearing from the Grand Library.

Chapter 1053 Gates of Heaven

Chapter 1053 Gates of Heaven

After Yuan left the Demon Sealing Clan's Grand Library, Yan Hara also left, returning to the Seventh Heaven where she currently resided.

Upon returning to her own realm, she retrieved multiple communication jade slips and contacted the people with the other jade slips to set up a meeting.

"Fellow sisters of the Divine Paragon Fanclub, I have something urgent to tell all of you. This involves the Divine Paragon and the future of the Demon Sealing Clan. Please meet me at the usual meeting spot as soon as possible. Thank you."

After transmitting such words through the communication jade slips, Yan Hara retrieved her flying treasure and disappeared into the distance like a shooting star.

Meanwhile, Yuan returned to the Myriad of Techniques.

"Sorry for making you all wait. I'm back now." Yuan said to the others, who were waiting in the lobby.

"Huh? Where are your techniques?" He asked them when he couldn't see any techniques nearby.

"Actually... We couldn't get past the second floor, and the techniques on the first two floors are not worth it." Chu Liuxiang sighed.

Yuan facepalmed after realizing something, "I'm sorry, I forgot that I had to be with you guys when traveling above the second floor. Let's go check out

the fourth floor and the fifth floor now."

"Alright."

Thus, they began making their way to the fourth floor.

Since Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang had already explored the fourth floor, they didn't really pay much attention and flipped through random techniques to kill time.

Meanwhile, Li Jinxi looked through each technique with great focus.

"Unbelievable... To think there are so many Heaven-rank and Divine-rank techniques in this place..." Li Jinxi mumbled.

"There are more floors to this place with even more powerful techniques." Yuan said.

Sometime later, after going through the whole fourth floor, Li Jinxi found one body refining technique that she liked.

"Are you done on this floor? If so, let's check out the fifth floor. This will be our first time going to the fifth floor as well." Yuan asked them.

"Yes, we're ready." They nodded.

Yuan and the others proceeded to move to the staircase to the fifth floor, but they were blocked by the guards there.

"Is this your first time going to the fifth floor?" One of the guards asked.

"Yes." Yuan nodded.

The guard then said, "In order to enter the fifth floor, you must pass a small trial."

"Trial? What kind of trial?"

"You must spar with a disciple from the Gates of Heaven."

"What?" Yuan raised his eyebrows, his face full of questions.

"In order to train his disciples, Master Bai had set up this trial. Don't worry, it'll be a friendly spar, and it'll be done in a special arena where you cannot die even if your body explodes into a bloody mess. However, the weakest cultivator in their sect is a Spirit Sovereign, so you'll be fighting someone two realms above your own..."

"Senior Bai is the Sect Leader of the Gates of Heaven? This is my first time hearing about this." Yuan mumbled.

"Alright, I will take on the challenge. But before we start, I have a few questions."

"What is it?"

"Does everybody here have to take the trial to enter the fifth floor? Can I bring them with me if I pass the trial?"

The guards turned to look at the beauties behind Yuan and said, "Everyone will have to take the trial in order to enter the fifth floor. There is no exception."

"..." Yuan turned to look at Meixiu and the others.

While he can fight a Spirit Sovereign, he couldn't say the same for Meixiu and the others, as their cultivation was too low, and they would lose in a single attack.

"Don't worry about us, Yuan. You can go to the fifth floor alone." Meixiu said to him.

"Yes. I am already satisfied with what I have." Chu Liuxiang agreed.

"I am also the same." Li Jinxi said.

"Alright... Then I will take a quick look at the fifth floor." Yuan nodded.

The guards looked at him with raised eyebrows, as he sounded absolutely sure that he would defeat a Spirit Sovereign.

"So where do I fight this disciple?" Yuan then asked the guards.

"Follow me. I will bring you to the arena." One of the guards said to him.

"Okay."

Sometime later, Yuan was transported to this large platform with the guard, but they were the only ones there.

'This place reminds me of the platform in the sky for the final trial in the Stairway to Heaven...' Yuan thought to himself as he looked around.

The only difference was the lack of house, tree, and the body tempering pond.

"Where is this disciple?" He asked the guard a moment later.

"I have just notified the Gates of Heaven about your arrival. A disciple will arrive shortly."

"I understand."

Half an hour later, two people appeared out of thin air on the platform not far away from Yuan and began approaching him.

"They are..." The guard's eyes widened with surprise when he saw these individuals, and he wondered to himself, 'Why are they here? There's no way this young man could defeat this disciple!'

Yuan silently stared at these two individuals. One of them was an old woman with an unfathomable aura around her, and the other was a beautiful young woman also with an unfathomable aura around her.

Even though their faces were tranquil and their steps were gentle and calm, Yuan could feel an indescribable pressure coming from these two women.

These two stopped walking a few meters in front of Yuan, and the old woman said a moment later, "So it's true. I couldn't believe it when you said that the challenger was a mere Spirit King, so I came here to see for myself which arrogant little runt dared to challenge our disciple with such a weak cultivation."

"Greetings, Elder Mai and Disciple Ling." The guard greeted them with a respectful bow.

"This young man wishes to enter the fifth floor and has agreed to challenge a disciple from the Gates of Heaven."

"Introduce yourself." The guard said while looking at Yuan.

"My name is Yuan, and I'm just an ordinary Spirit King. Please treat me well." He calmly responded while staring into the old woman's eyes.

"Little runt..." Elder Mai narrowed her eyes on him.

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Chapter 1054 Immortal Rendering Sword Strike

Chapter 1054 Immortal Rendering Sword Strike

"Let's just get this over with, shall we?" Disciple Ling suddenly spoke as she retrieved her sword.

"Aren't you going to introduce yourself too?" Yuan asked her.

"And what are you going to do with such information? It's not like we'll ever meet again."

"Is that so..." Although he didn't like her attitude, Yuan didn't care about it either. After all, this will most likely be their first and last meeting.

The guard cleared his throat and said, "Then the rules are as followed. The two of you will fight each other until one of you either loses consciousness or dies. This arena is being protected with an Immortal Array, so you won't truly die even if you die as long as you are on this platform."

He then turned to look at Yuan and said, "If you lose this fight, you will not be able to challenge the Gates of Heaven again until 1 whole year has passed. Do you understand?"

"I understand."

"Good. Then please stand in the red circles. I will begin the fight in ten seconds."

Yuan turned around to see a red circle marked on the platform a few meters and walked to it.

His sparring partner also did the same.

Once they were both in the red circle, Elder Mai and the guard moved away to give them space.

"The fight will now begin!" The guard shouted ten seconds later.

However, neither Yuan nor his opponent, Disciple Ling, moved even seconds after the match had started.

"What's wrong? Are you too scared to move?" Disciple Ling said in a provocative manner.

"No, I'm just wondering why you're not moving even though you said that you wanted this to be over as soon as possible." Yuan smiled. "If I was in a hurry, you'd have lost by now."

Disciple Ling narrowed her eyes.

"A mere Spirit King dares to look down on me?!" Disciple Ling's cultivation base suddenly soared.

'Peak Spirit Sovereign, huh? Exactly two realms above me...' Yuan thought to himself.

"What a foolish little runt. He doesn't even know the difference between a Spirit King and a Spirit Sovereign." A cold smile appeared on Elder Mai's face.

The guard merely shook his head.

'Disciple Ling is one of the most talented disciples in the Gates of Heaven within the Fifth Heaven. There's no way some Spirit King would be able to defeat her...'

Even though people were allowed access to the fifth floor the moment they entered the Third Heaven, most people won't be able to pass the trial until they're at least a Spirit Sovereign.

"DIE!" Disciple Ling suddenly slashed her sword at Yuan without moving outside her red circle.

A powerful sword light that was infused with Sword Aura flew at Yuan at incredible speed, reaching him in the blink of an eye.

However, despite such a powerful strike flying at him, Yuan remained standing there without moving, almost as if he had no intentions of blocking the attack.

"So you came here just to waste my time, huh?" Disciple Ling mumbled in a disappointed voice after seeing Yuan's lack of reaction.

Whoosh!

The sword light clashed with Yuan's bare body a split second later.

Yuan was forced out of the red circle and pushed many meters away by the sword light, which baffled Disciple Ling and the two spectators.

"H-He survived the attack?" The guard mumbled in a dazed voice.

Yuan was a Spirit King, and he'd just eaten the attack from a Spirit Sovereign with his bare body. It didn't make sense that his body wasn't immediately sliced in half by the attack.

After the attack, Yuan casually patted his chest and walked back into the red circle.

"Is that all you've got? I barely felt that. I guess Spirit Sovereigns aren't that much stronger than a Spirit King, after all." Yuan said with a mocking smile on his face.

Disciple Ling's body trembled in anger after hearing his words.

"If you thought that was my full power, you're dead wrong! That wasn't even 25 percent of my full power! I just didn't want to feel like I am bullying a weakling, so I purposefully held back!" She exclaimed.

"Is that so? Then can you use 100 percent of your power next? I'd like to see what you're truly capable of." Yuan said.

"Unbelievable... This little runt is actually provoking her to use her full strength..." Elder Mai muttered in a dazed voice.

"If that's what you want, then I will fulfill that wish!" Disciple Ling shouted as she swung her sword again.

This time, the sword light took the appearance of a blue dragon as it flew towards Yuan.

'Oh... Not bad...' Yuan thought to himself as he retrieved his Empyrean Overlord.

[Immortal Rendering Sword Strike!]

Yuan used this sword technique for the first time after seeing Tian Yang use it in his dream.

[Immortal Rendering Sword Strike!]

[rank: ancient]

[description: a devastating sword strike that will render even immortals powerless!]

Whoosh!

A massive wave of Sword Aura immediately swept the arena in front of him, consuming the blue dragon as well as Disciple Ling in an instant.

"Wha—?!"

Disciple Ling couldn't even react in time before her body was completely destroyed by the devastating attack.

The guard fell on his buttocks after witnessing the attack, and Elder Mai could only stand there with her eyes and mouth wide open, almost as if she

witnessed the impossible.

Shortly after Disciple Ling's body was disintegrated into countless fragments, her body suddenly reappeared out of thin air on the floor, but she wasn't moving.

"Li-Ling'er!" Elder Mai immediately rushed to check on her disciple's condition.

She sighed in relief after confirming that Disciple Ling was indeed alive.

Then she turned to look at Yuan with a furious expression on her face. With that being said, she didn't show any signs of killing intent, which surprised Yuan.

"What was your name again?" Elder Mai asked him.

"Yuan."

"Where are you from?"

"Where I am currently, or where I came from?"

"Both."

He smiled and said, "I came from the Lower Heavens, and I am currently in the Third Heaven."

'Lower Heavens?! Impossible!' Elder Mai cried inwardly.

Chapter 1055 Nine Heavens

Eternal Grotto

Chapter 1055 Nine Heavens Eternal Grotto

"You said your name was Yuan, right? You never gave us your surname." Elder Mai asked him a moment later, as she suspected that he was from an influential family.

"I don't have anything like that. Anyways, if the match is over, can I leave now? I have people waiting for me outside." Yuan said in a calm manner.

"You think you can just leave after what you did to my disciple?" Elder Mai narrowed her eyes at him, but once again, Yuan couldn't sense any threatening feeling from it.

"Don't tell me you're going to fight me next even though I already won the match?" He asked her.

"Why would I fight you? I was just going to—"

A portal suddenly appeared a few meters away from Yuan and Elder Mai.

Then, an old man with long white hair calmly walked out of the portal with his hands clasped behind his back.

When Elder Mai and the guard saw him, they immediately bowed to him, "Sect Master Bai!"

"Senior Bai? What are you doing here?" Yuan was pleasantly surprised to see him appear in this place.

"How disrespectful! Do you know who you're before?! Lower your head and greet him!" Elder Mai suddenly shouted at him.

"It's fine. This young man is my friend." Senior Bai gestured for her to calm her with a gentle smile on his face.

"..." Elder Mai was speechless.

"I've watched your fight just now, Yuan. I must say, you've grown tremendously since our last meeting, and even your appearance changed a bit. You're almost like a different person." Senior Bai said while approaching him.

"Anyways, why don't we chat in a more quiet place?"

"Sure." Yuan nodded.

Senior Bai proceeded to make another portal before entering it.

Yuan didn't say anything to the others and followed Senior Bai, disappearing from the platform.

Once they were gone, Elder Mai turned to look at the guard and asked him, "Who was that young man just now? Is it true that he came from the Third Heaven?"

He nodded, "Yes, it's true, but I don't know anything about him. He came out of the blue and requested to go to the fifth floor."

Elder Mai turned to look at her disciple, who was still unconscious, and sighed, "When I heard that a Spirit King dared to challenge the Gates of Heaven, I immediately thought about putting this ignorant little runt in his place. However, it turns out that I had been the ignorant one. I hope this defeat won't hinder my disciple's future cultivation too much, but honestly, I'm probably hoping for too much, as even I would be depressed after such a devastating defeat."

Elder Mai carried her unconscious disciple away, disappearing from the platform, leaving the guard alone and puzzled.

After following Senior Bai, Yuan found himself on the floating platform again.

"I was really shocked when I saw your improvements, especially when I realized that you have achieved a Perfect Physique." Senior Bai said to him once they sat down.

"Do you know how many people out there would kill for a Perfect Physique? I remember trying to acquire one myself, but I failed, yet here you are, not even a hundred years old and already with a Perfect Physique." Senior Bai chuckled in a bittersweet manner.

"Did something happen?" Yuan asked him.

He nodded, "Do you remember when I told you about the Nine Heavens Eternal Grotto?"

"The four escaped immortals?"

"Yes. We managed to track down three of them and brought two of them back to the Nine Heavens Eternal Grotto, but it was at a heavy cost. Thousands of cultivators died, and a few of my good friends also perished during the struggle."

"Wait... Only two returned to the Nine Heavens Eternal Grotto? Did they kill one of them?" Yuan asked.

"Hardly. The third Immortal had managed to escape. And that's why I am reaching out to you." Senior Bai said, and he continued, "The escaped Immortal had somehow managed to escape to the lower heavens, so you might come across this Immortal."

"Wa-Wait a minute... Isn't that very bad? What if they suddenly decide to wreak havoc in the lower heavens? I don't think I have the capabilities to do anything to this Immortal."

"I am well aware of that. I'm not telling you to seek this Immortal and kill them for me. I am just letting you know so that you're aware of the

situation. With that being said, the Immortal is heavily injured after escaping, so they will be powerless for a bit."

Yuan nodded, "I won't be actively searching for this Immortal, but I will keep a lookout for them. Do you know which of the lower heaven they've runned to? And what about this Immortal's appearance?"

"The Immortal can be anywhere between the Third Heaven and the Sixth Heaven. As for their appearance... To be honest, we don't know either. This Immortal is always shrouded with darkness, so we can't tell their gender or appearance."

"Shrouded with darkness, huh?"

"Even if you don't know their appearance, you will immediately know if this Immortal is nearby." Senior Bai suddenly said.

"How?" Yuan raised an eyebrow.

"You will understand it once you feel it. Even if this Immortal suppresses their cultivation, they cannot suppress their natural aura. You will feel an intense chill down your spine when this Immortal is near."

"I understand." Yuan nodded.

Sometime later, Senior Bai spoke, "Anyways, now that is out of the way, do you have any questions for me before I leave?"

"Actually, I do. Do you think it's possible for me to bring my friends to the fifth floor of the Myriad of Techniques? I want to give them some techniques."

"You mean your girlfriends?" Senior Bai smiled.

Yuan nodded, not denying it.

"I will make an exception for you only if you do me a favor." Senior Bai then said.

"What kind of favor?"

"I will let you know when the time comes. Don't worry, it's nothing dangerous or crazy. You can even refuse it when the time comes and you don't like it."

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AN: Since this is a new ark and we've just arrived in the Third Heaven, I needed to take a few days to outline the plot. There will be 4+ more chapters today.

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Chapter 1056 Attacking Senior Bai

Chapter 1056 Attacking Senior Bai

After pondering for a moment, Yuan agreed to Senior Bai's offer, "Since I can refuse it, I don't mind."

"Great. Then take this." Senior Bai proceeded to hand him a medallion.

"As long as you have this, you will be able to take as many people as you want to the floors that you currently have access to, so you won't be able to go to the sixth floor right now since you don't have access to it. Is this good enough?"

"This is more than enough! Thank you, Senior!" Yuan bowed to him before accepting the medallion.

"Anything else?"

"A few more, actually." Yuan said with a smile.

"Does the Myriad of Techniques have any soul cultivation techniques?" He then asked.

"Soul cultivation techniques? Those are incredibly rare even in the upper heavens. As generous as I am, even I wouldn't put something that precious in the Myriad of Techniques."

"I see... That's a pity."

"Why do you want a soul cultivation technique? Are you cultivating any spiritual techniques at the moment?"

Yuan nodded, "Yes, I am."

Senior Bai pondered for a moment before speaking, "Show me this technique. I will help you acquire a soul cultivation technique if I think it's worth it."

"Show you? You want me to attack you?" Yuan asked just in case there was a misunderstanding.

"That's right." Senior Bai said as he flew off the platform and into the spacious sky.

"Don't worry about hurting me. If you can injure me with your cultivation, I will immediately quit being a cultivator."

Yuan smiled and said, "Are you sure you want to say such a risky thing? I might accidentally hurt you."

Senior Bai laughed, "Then how about this? If you can hurt me, I will not only help you find a soul cultivation technique, but I will also pay for it."

"Deal!"

Yuan flew off the platform and hovered about 50 meters away from Senior Bai.

"Whenever you're ready." Senior Bai said, acting completely nonchalant about the whole situation, clearly very confident that Yuan wouldn't be able to hurt him no matter what.

Yuan didn't immediately attack Senior Bai as well, and he silently pondered, 'His cultivation is incredibly profound. Besides Xu Jiaqi and the Great One, he's definitely the strongest cultivator I have encountered.'

Yuan knew that he wouldn't be able to damage Senior Bai if he half-assed his attempt. Therefore, he could only go all out and treat it as though it was a life-or-death situation.

He closed his eyes and took several deep breaths.

When he reopened them, his eyes emanated a golden glow that sent shivers down Senior Bai's back.

'What is he doing?' Senior Bai swallowed nervously.

Whoosh!

A golden aura suddenly shrouded Yuan's figure, causing the atmosphere there to change.

'This is...!' Senior Bai's eyes widened with shock after sensing the unfathomable pressure from the aura.

In his entire life, this is probably the most powerful technique that he's witnessed.

'The technique is neither flashy nor grand, but it exudes an unfathomable pressure that would make even Immortals tremble in fear! Before this golden aura, one's cultivation and talent doesn't matter! This technique transcends all common sense and the very law of this universe! Where did he learn such a heaven-defying technique?!

After activating Heaven's Supremacy, Yuan took another deep breath.

'I didn't think I would use the second one so quickly after the first, but this is for the soul cultivation technique. It's worth it as long as I can damage Senior Bai even slightly.'

[God of War's Astral Arts!]

Yuan proceeded to use his second most powerful technique, summoning the golden avatar behind him.

Senior Bai had to tilt his head to see the avatar, his eyes and mouth wide open from shock.

'Impossible! This technique— This technique is God of War's Astral Arts! Why does he know this technique?!'

Senior Bai recognized this technique, but that only made him even more shocked.

Because Yuan had Heaven's Supremacy active, his avatar created by the God of War's Astral Arts was many times larger than before, and compared to the avatar, Senior Bai's figure was akin to a speck of dust.

"Heavens... What have I gotten myself into...?" Senior Bai muttered in a dazed voice as Yuan made his first movement.

He slashed horizontally, sending the massive sword wielded by the avatar crashing down on Senior Bai.

However, despite that, Senior Bai didn't move and remained hovering there with his arms clasped behind his back.

BOOM!

The sword clashed with Senior Bai's body the next moment, creating a powerful ripple that swept all of the clouds away, as well as the nearby platforms.

Yuan gritted his teeth when he saw that the attack hadn't been able to push Senior Bai back even an inch.

Therefore, he decided to attack again.

BOOM!

Since Senior Bai didn't specify how many times he could attack him, Yuan would continue to send a barrage of attacks at Senior Bai's way until he ran out of spiritual energy and soul strength.

And during his last strike, Yuan poured all of his spiritual energy and soul strength into the attack.

The attack was so powerful that it could probably destroy an entire continent.

Despite that, Senior Bai remained in the same position, seemingly unharmed from all of the attacks.

A bittersweet smile appeared on Yuan's face after seeing the results.

"I give up. You're much stronger than I thought, Senior Bai." Yuan said to him as his golden aura and avatar went away.

"..."

Senior Bai didn't respond.

It was at this moment Yuan finally noticed the expression on Senior Bai's face, and he looked like someone who just learned a shocking revelation, as his face was absolutely hysterical and filled with shock.

Yuan swallowed nervously after seeing this, and he waited for Senior Bai to snap out of his daze.

Several moments later, Senior Bai closed his mouth and eyes and took a deep breath.

"Looks like I won't be able to leave anytime soon, as we still have a lot to talk about, Yuan."

Chapter 1057 Founder of the Celestial Overlord

Chapter 1057 Founder of the Celestial Overlord

With a casual wave of his sleeves, Senior Bai refilled the empty landscape with clouds and floating platforms.

He flew to the nearest platform and proceeded to wait for Yuan, who was completely exhausted after unleashing literally all of his strongest attacks on Senior Bai.

Yuan took a seat, but Senior Bai remained standing there for some reason.

"You don't have to answer this question if you don't want to, nor am I going to force you. Yuan, that technique you used just now— God of War's Astral Arts, where did you learn it?" Senior Bai suddenly asked him.

Yuan's eyes widened slightly, as he didn't expect Senior Bai to recognize such an ancient technique.

"I encountered it by chance— that is all I'm willing to say. Sorry." Yuan said after a moment of silence.

Senior Bai shook his head, "There's no need for you to apologize. I am the one who should apologize since I am the one breaking the unspoken rule of never asking another cultivator about how they acquired their techniques."

"Now allow me to ask you another question— do you know the origin of that technique?"

"No, I do not." Yuan lied with a straight face.

As much as he trusts Senior Bai, he believed that the fewer people knew about his past lives the better. After all, there could be enemies out there that he didn't know about, and if news of his reincarnation spread, he could potentially be hunted by ancient monsters that have lived for millions of years, especially since one of his past lives was the Evil God.

"The God of War's Astral Arts... It was the Founder of the Celestial Overlord's technique." Senior Bai said with a solemn look on his face.

"Eh?" Yuan raised an eyebrow after hearing this unexpected answer.

'Founder of the Celestial Overlord? Unless the God of War also happened to be the Celestial Overlord's founder, that shouldn't be possible.'

"I have a question. What era did the Celestial Overlord's Founder exist in?"

"Around two million years ago."

'2 million years... The God of War should've existed in the Primordial Era, so they cannot be the same person. The only explanation for this is— the Founder of the Celestial Overlord is one of my past lives, and Senior Bai believes that he is the original owner of the God of War's Astral Arts when that is not the case.'

Although he had his suspicions that the founder of the Celestial Overlord was one of his past lives because they both had the same physique, there wasn't any other proof until now.

"Hm? Two million years ago? You're that old? Amazing..." Yuan realized this and praised him.

"It's only two million years. There are plenty of monsters out there that have lived far longer than I." Senior Bai shook his head.

"One more question, Senior Bai. Do you know the name of the founder?" Yuan then asked, as he wanted to see if he could remember anything after hearing the name.

However, Senior Bai shook his head and said, "Unfortunately, I wasn't worthy to hear his name. If you want to know his name, you will have to ask Xu Jiaqi. She's the only member left who knows his name."

"Is that so... Thank you."

"If you don't have any other questions, I will continue asking mine."

"Go ahead." Yuan nodded.

"My next question is related to that golden aura. I have seen similar techniques before, but none of them exuded such a terrifying pressure. Just thinking about it makes my skin crawl. Does it have a name?"

Yuan showed a bittersweet smile and said, "I'm really sorry, but I also have no idea. I don't even know how I acquired the technique, but it seems to boost my strength by a tremendous amount."

"Do you think I can take a closer look at it?" Senior Bai suddenly asked.

"About that... I also don't know how to control it. It only appears when it feels like it. It was by pure coincidence that I managed to use it just now as well, probably because I really wanted the soul cultivation technique."

Senior Bai pondered for a moment before speaking, "That technique is incredibly profound and powerful. The day you can control it is the day you will control the Nine Heavens— that is what I believe it."

"Control the Nine Heavens? I don't have such ambitions." Yuan chuckled.

The two of them continued to talk for a little longer before Senior Bai said, "Anyways, as much as I want to continue chatting with you, it's about time I leave. Do you have anything else for me?"

"Actually, I do." Yuan nodded, and he continued, "Now that I am a peak Spirit King, my cultivation won't continue until I upgrade my physique, but I still have no idea how to do so. I have tempered my body and even achieved Perfect Physique, but it doesn't seem to have any effects on my Heaven Refining Physique. Can you ask Miss Xu if she could help me find

more information about my physique? I'm sure the upper heavens will have more information than what's available down here."

Senior Bai nodded, "I don't mind. I am going to see her in a bit, anyway. As for your soul cultivation technique... I will help you find one."

"Thank you." Yuan bowed to him before leaving the place and returning to the Myriad of Techniques.

Once Yuan left, Senior Bai looked at his hands that were still trembling from excitement and mumbled, "He really attacked me with the intention of killing me. If it weren't for my cultivation, I would've been in danger there... No, even with my cultivation, he actually managed to pierce my defenses and land a hit on me."

Although Yuan had managed to land a hit on Senior Bai, he didn't leave any marks, so Senior Bai is technically unharmed.

"With that being said, the fact that he, a mere Spirit King, was able to break through my defense, is a miracle in itself. If people knew that a Spirit King had landed a hit on me, they would try to covet his talent at all cost, and I would become a laughingstock... This is a secret that I must take to the grave..." Senior Bai left the place with a bittersweet smile.

Chapter 1058 A Trade

Chapter 1058 A Trade

Sometime after leaving his world that was connected with the Myriad of Techniques, Senior Bai went to meet with Xu Jiaqi.

"Lady Xu, I apologize for keeping you waiting. The young man came to the Myriad of Techniques again and I couldn't help myself and went to speak with him. He's changed a lot since our last meeting— both his appearance and strength." Senior Bai said to Xu Jiaqi shortly after arriving.

"Young man...? Are you talking about 'him'? What did you talk about with him?" Xu Jiaqi's interest was immediately piqued.

Senior Bai couldn't help but smile at her reaction.

'She normally keeps herself out of other people's business, but when it comes to Yuan, she always wants to be involved...'

"You're not going to believe me when I say this, but he managed to defeat a Spirit Sovereign as a Spirit King during a trial to access the fifth floor of the Myriad of Techniques, and it was an overwhelming victory on his end."

"Not bad, I suppose." Xu Jiaqi said in a nonchalant manner, seemingly not impressed by it.

'That kind of talent is only natural for someone with the Heaven Refining Physique,' she thought to herself.

"After the match, we had a small conversation, and he wanted me to help him look for a soul cultivation technique."

"Did you agree to help him?" She asked.

He nodded, "Yes, I did, but only after I tested him."

"Don't be too shocked when you hear this, but that young man... He somehow acquired the technique that the Celestial Overlord's founder used — the God of War's Astral Arts."

"HE WHAT?!?!?" Xu Jiaqi suddenly exclaimed in a voice so powerful that it literally shook the entire place.

"Are you sure it was the God of War's Astral Arts?!" She quickly asked him.

"Yes, I am certain, since he used it on me as part of the test." Senior Bai nodded.

"God of War's Astral Arts..." Xu Jiaqi took a few steps back and stared at the ground with a dazed look on her face.

Over the next several moments, she would recall the memories of the God of War's Astral Arts being used by the founder of the Celestial Overlord.

"Where... Did he tell you where he found it...?" Xu Jiaqi suddenly asked in a low voice.

"I tried asking, but he didn't want to tell me. I don't blame him, considering how valuable that technique is."

"..."

After another moment of silence, a resolute look appeared on Xu Jiaqi's ethereal face as she spoke, "Bring me to the Myriad of Techniques. I want to speak with him."

"Eh? What about the meeting? The Celestial Emperor will be at the meeting this time as well. It wouldn't be wise to..."

Xu Jiaqi glared at him with a sharp gaze that could literally pierce one's body. Fortunately for Senior Bai, his cultivation was high enough to block the gaze.

"Alright..." Senior Bai quickly gave up and sighed with a bittersweet smile on his face.

He then opened a portal to his world and entered it with Xu Jiaqi.

Meanwhile, Yuan had just returned to the Myriad of Techniques and entered the fifth floor with the others after showing the guard Senior Bai's medallion.

"I can't believe it... Did he really beat a disciple from the Gates of Heaven?" The guard that stayed behind asked the other guard who led Yuan to the arena.

The guard nodded with a nervous look on his face, "Not only did he defeat the disciple, he completely destroyed her."

"Did they give him a super weak opponent because of his Spirit King cultivation?"

The guard shook his head, "No... You probably won't believe this, but his opponent wasn't an Outer Court disciple but an Inner Court disciple, and it was the famous Disciple Ling."

"Disciple Ling?! You don't mean—"

"Exactly that Disciple Ling."

"Unbelievable... No wonder why Senior Bai gave him the medallion..."

At the fifth floor, Yuan said to the ladies, "Go ahead and look around. Let me know when you're done because I will also be looking around."

"Okay."

However, shortly after he started looking at the techniques, Senior Bai's voice resounded inside his head as a portal appeared beside him.

"Yuan, I'm sorry, but can you come back for a moment? Xu Jiaqi would like to speak with you, and she won't take no for an answer."

'Xu Jiaqi...? What does she want from me?' Yuan wondered to himself.

"Xiao Hua, Feng Feng, Yingying, can you wait for me here?" He said to them, as he didn't want to risk Xu Jiaqi meeting with Xiao Hua, and not wanting her to be left out, he asked the others to stay with her.

Once they left his body, Yuan said to them, "Thank you. I will be right back. And if the others ask where I am, let them know where I went."

Yuan entered the portal shortly after, disappearing from the Myriad of Techniques and appearing in Senior Bai's world literally minutes after he just left.

When he arrived at the platform Senior Bai and Xu Jiaqi were waiting, Yuan bowed to them.

"Greetings, Lady Xu and Senior Bai."

Xu Jiaqi raised an eyebrow after noticing the way he addressed her had changed from Miss Xu to Lady Xu, implying that he was no longer as ignorant as before.

"Yuan, I won't waste your time and get straight to the point. I want the God of War's Astral Arts." Xu Jiaqi suddenly said.

"Eh?" Yuan looked at her with widened eyes, clearly surprised by her sudden demand.

Seeing his reaction, Xu Jiaqi continued, "Of course, I am not asking you to hand over the technique for free. You're looking for a soul cultivation technique, right? In exchange for the God of War's Astral Arts, I will give you the strongest soul cultivation technique that I can acquire."

'She wants to trade a soul cultivation technique for my God of War's Astral Arts? Why does she want this technique? What does it mean to her?' Yuan silently wondered to himself.

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Chapter 1059 Xu Jiaqi

Chapter 1059 Xu Jiaqi

'Although the God of War's Astral Arts is a powerful technique, I don't mind sharing it, especially if I can acquire a powerful soul cultivation technique from it. Xu Jiaqi, she's a powerful cultivator with plenty of influence even within the upper heavens. If it's someone like her, I will definitely acquire an extremely powerful soul cultivation technique...'

While Yuan pondered, Xu Jiaqi suddenly said in a low voice, "In your eyes, the God of War's Astral Arts may be nothing more than a powerful technique. However, the God of War's Astral Arts is more than just a technique to me— it's the founder of the Celestial Overlord— my father's technique."

"Huh?" Yuan suddenly halted all of his thoughts and looked at Xu Jiaqi's beautiful face with a baffled look on his face.

"W-What did you say? The founder of the Celestial Overlord is your father...?" Yuan didn't dare to believe it.

If Xu Jiaqi was truly his daughter in his past life, then what would their relationship be right now? Would they still be considered father and daughter?

"Yes, he is my father, but we're not blood-related. He saved my life when I was on the verge of death. I was just a young mortal who didn't even know about cultivation at that time, and ever since then, I followed him around the Nine Heavens while training under him. We started out as a teacher and disciple, but he eventually accepted me as his adoptive daughter."

Yuan was relieved to find out that Xu Jiaqi wasn't his real daughter but an adoptive one.

'Since she's my adoptive daughter, I guess there's no harm in giving her the technique.'

After taking a deep breath, Yuan spoke in a calm voice, "Alright, you have a deal. In exchange for my God of War's Astral Arts, you will give me a soul cultivation technique."

"Really?!" An excited look appeared on Xu Jiaqi's face, but she quickly concealed it, returning to her serious face.

"Yes, for real. Give me your forehead, I will transfer the technique to you right now." Yuan said.

"Huh? You're willing to give it to me right now even though I don't even have your soul cultivation technique? Are you stupid or what?" Xu Jiaqi couldn't help but make this remark even though it could easily backfire on her.

Yuan chuckled at her insult, "That's quite harsh, Lady Xu. How can you call me stupid when I am doing this out of generosity and trust?"

Xu Jiaqi cleared her throat after hearing his words, "I apologize, I subconsciously blurted that out just now because I was surprised that you would be willing to hand over such a powerful technique to me so easily. I am not used to it."

"So do you want the technique now or...?" Yuan continued to smile.

"I do."

Xu Jiaqi nodded before she leaned forward.

Yuan calmly raised his arm and gently tapped her forehead.

"..." Senior Bai watched this historical moment with wide eyes.

'This is the first time I've seen Lady Xu willingly let another man touch her body, and even on her bare skin directly...' He thought to himself.

Meanwhile, Yuan transferred the God of War's Astral Arts to Xu Jiaqi, who felt oddly nostalgic for some reason.

'This feeling... It's the same as when Father transferred his techniques to me...' Xu Jiaqi thought to herself as she quickly absorbed the information.
FreewebNovel.com.

A few moments later, Xu Jiaqi opened her eyes, which flickered with profoundness within.

"It's done." Yuan lowered his hand and said to her.

Xu Jiaqi didn't say anything and suddenly turned around before flying off the platform, almost as if she was running away.

However, she stopped shortly after and proceeded to hover in the air.

A few moments later, her body suddenly exuded an unfathomable aura that swept the place like a tsunami.

"Thank you, Senior Bai." Yuan suddenly said.

"No problem." Senior Bai smiled.

If Senior Bai hadn't protected him with his own spiritual energy right before Xu Jiaqi released her pressure, he would've sustained heavy internal injuries.

Of course, Xu Jiaqi was also confident that Senior Bai would protect Yuan.

'Even with Senior Bai protecting me, my body feels incredibly heavy, almost as though I have a star on my back! So this is what it's like to be a cultivator at the peak of the Nine Heavens!' Yuan began sweating profusely, his body quickly becoming soaked.

Suddenly, a massive golden avatar materialized behind Xu Jiaqi, which had some differences compared to Yuan's avatar.

Xu Jiaqi's avatar was not only much larger, but it was also clearly a female avatar, almost like a goddess, and the weapon it was wielding also looked different.

"Damn..." Yuan subconsciously muttered out loud when he saw the majestic avatar behind Xu Jiaqi.

"That isn't even half of her full power." Senior Bai suddenly said, "If she unleashes any more of her power, this space will be destroyed, so she's holding back right now."

Yuan swallowed nervously after hearing such words.

Meanwhile, Xu Jiaqi had her head turned and tilted as her gaze was fixated on the avatar behind her.

'Father...'

Sometime later, Xu Jiaqi deactivated the technique and returned to the platform.

"So? What did you think? Is it the same God of War's Astral Arts the same one you know?" Yuan asked her with a smile.

"Yes, it's definitely the same technique. I owe you for this, Yuan."

"Lady Xu... I hate to interrupt you, but they're calling for us." Senior Bai suddenly said while pointing to the communication jade slip resting on his palm.

Xu Jiaqi sighed, "We have to go now, Yuan. Come back here in one month. I will have your soul cultivation technique ready by then."

"Take your time, Lady Xu." Yuan nodded with a smile on his face.

Senior Bai created a portal for Yuan to leave shortly after.

Once he was gone, Senior Bai and Xu Jiaqi also left that world before making their way to the meeting.

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Chapter 1060 Lost Legacy

Chapter 1060 Lost Legacy

As they made their way to the meeting, Senior Bai realized something, "Oh yeah, Lady Xu, I forgot to tell you. Yuan also wants to see if you can acquire any more information on the Heaven Refining Physique. He's acquired the Perfect Physique, but his Heaven Refining Physique hasn't been upgraded yet."

"I will look into that after I acquire the soul cultivation technique," she calmly said.

Senior Bai smiled and said, "Because you're going to help him find a soul cultivation technique, my agreement with him is now useless. I guess I will have to find something else to give him."

He'd promised Yuan that he'd help him find a soul cultivation technique if Yuan could injure him. But since Xu Jiaqi is also giving him a soul cultivation technique, he would only be wasting resources by giving Yuan another soul cultivation technique—one that will most likely be inferior to the one Xu Jiaqi will be giving him. Therefore, he decided to find something else to give Yuan.

'He really resembles Father...' Xu Jiaqi silently recalled Yuan's appearance.

Now that Yuan looked more mature and even grew a little taller, his resemblance to the founder of the Celestial Overlord became even more clearer and obvious to her.

When she first met Yuan, she noticed that Yuan and her adoptive father had similar eyes, but everything else from his demeanor to his aura was completely different. This was the same during their second meeting.

However, on their third meeting just now, Yuan had changed so much that she almost mistook him for her father.

'Why does he resemble father so much? Don't tell me he's one of my father's true descendants? No... father never had a wife or childrens— at least not to my knowledge.'

Sometime later, they arrived at the meeting, where hundreds of individuals were gathered.

Each of these individuals emanated an unfathomable aura that only Immortal cultivators that have achieved the apex of cultivation could emit.

"How can you be this late when the Celestial Emperor himself had scheduled this meeting, Xu Jiaqi? Bai Linyu? We even had to contact you before you showed up." One of the figures there said out loud when they arrived, her voice filled with contempt.

"You better have a good explanation for making the Celestial Emperor wait." Another person said.

"How disrespectful to the Celestial Emperor. The Celestial Overlords are getting more arrogant by the day."

Multiple people there expressed their disdain without any filters or fear for Xu Jiaqi. It was clear that she had some enemies within this place.

However, Xu Jiaqi remained tranquil and said, "Is this the right place for the meeting? I didn't know dogs would be allowed to participate. Color me surprised."

"Xu Jiaqi! You bitch! You dare call us dogs?!"

"I sure did. What are you going to do about it? Bite me? Go ahead and try it if you dare."

"Settle down." A calm yet authoritative voice suddenly resounded in the meeting room.

This voice carried a profound aura that made these Immortals that could destroy stars with a fist subconsciously lower their heads.

Xu Jiaqi turned to look at the person who just spoke. He was sitting at the end of the room and was looking down at them from a tall platform.

"Why are you late, Celestial Overlord Xu?" The voice returned.

"I had some important matters to attend first," she calmly responded.

"Oh? A matter that is even more important than what is happening here? I'd like to hear it if you don't mind." The voice sounded genuinely curious.

And without explaining further, Xu Jiaqi suddenly released her cultivation, sending ripples throughout the area.

"W-What the hell do you think you're doing in the Celestial Emperor's presence?!"

"Have you gone mad, Xu Jiaqi?!"

"Stop it right now!"

The people there shouted when they sensed her indomitable aura, but nobody there actually dared to stop her, as they were all waiting for the others to move first.

As for the Celestial Emperor, he remained on his golden throne with a calm expression on his face, seemingly unfazed by the development.

A few seconds later, a massive golden avatar materialized behind Xu Jiaqi, shocking everyone in the room, as most of them actually recognized this technique.

"This is..." Even the Celestial Emperor couldn't remain calm after seeing the God of War's Astral Arts.

"This is why I am late. Do I need to explain myself any further?" Xu Jiaqi spoke a moment later.

"Is that technique what I think it is?" The Celestial Emperor asked her.

"God of War's Astral Arts..." The people there muttered after hearing the Celestial Emperor's question.

"Would you like to see for yourself whether this technique is real or not, Your Majesty?" Xu Jiaqi asked him with a daring smile on her face.

The Celestial Emperor chuckled, "As much as I want to entertain a beauty such as yourself, I will have to decline your offer. This place has history that goes all the way back to the Primordial Realm, so I would prefer it if we don't make a mess here. Now if you'll excuse me..."

The Celestial Emperor suddenly waved his sleeves in a casual manner, and the very next moment, the golden avatar behind Xu Jiaqi shattered into countless tiny fragments.

"Anyways, does this mean you have found the Founder of Celestial Overlord's lost legacy?" The Celestial Emperor then asked her.

"..."

Xu Jiaqi remained silent, but not because she didn't want to answer his question. In fact, she couldn't, as she didn't know either.

'I was too hasty to acquire the technique and forgot to ask Yuan where he'd acquired the technique.' She sighed inwardly.

After a moment of silence, she said, "I don't know because I had to rush here right after acquiring the technique."

"You don't know? Then how did you acquire it?" The Celestial Emperor asked out of curiosity.

"I will not be sharing such information, considering how many people here covet my father's legacy." Xu Jiaqi calmly said as she swept the crowd there with a cold gaze.

Chapter 1061 Celestial Emperor's Request

Chapter 1061 Celestial Emperor's Request

"You're right. I was being insensitive just now. Let's end the topic here and return to the reason I've gathered all of you here today." The Celestial Emperor said a moment later.

When the people there heard this, they cursed inwardly.

'Fuck! That Xu Jiaqi definitely found their ancestor's lost legacy! Considering how powerful their ancestor was when he was alive, the Celestial Overlord will become more powerful than ever now! This is bad! The Celestial Overlords will completely overshadow the other factions—our faction soon!'

The immortals there were nervous because the Celestial Overlords were already at the top of the faction ranking. Now that they have their ancestor's lost legacy, their power will skyrocket, allowing them to completely dominate the faction ranking, and nobody there wanted that to happen.

However, there was nothing they could do about it. Unless they could somehow steal the lost legacy from the Celestial Overlords, the Celestial Overlords will, without doubt, grow.

Sometime later, once Xu Jiaqi and Senior Bai took their seats, the Celestial Emperor spoke, "I have gathered all of you today for one simple reason."

After a slight pause, he continued, "The 'Heavens' have spoken recently."

"What?!"

Everybody there was shocked to hear this, including Xu Jiaqi.

"Not long ago, the Heavens became aware of a certain individual. The Heavens believe this person to be related to the Evil God and demand for his extermination as soon as possible."

"Evil God?!" Everybody there experienced another wave of shock after hearing this name. Follow current novels on FreeWebnovel.com.

'Evil God... The monster that soaked the Nine Heavens in blood and a heretic who slayed the first Celestial Emperor... Why is his name relevant in this day and age?!' The Immortals wondered to themselves.

The Celestial Emperor continued, "I know what all of you are thinking. What does the Evil God have to do with this, and what in Heavens' name is happening? Unfortunately, I don't have the answers at this moment. All I know is that we must exterminate this person as soon as possible before he does anything crazy. And before you ask, I do not know the identity of this person nor his appearance. However, I do know that he was last spotted in the Third Heaven."

"The Third Heaven?" The people there became even more puzzled.

How could someone with connections to the Evil God be in such a lowly place?

Someone there suddenly raised his hand and said, "Your Majesty, if this person is in the Third Heaven, there's nothing we can do about it. Or are you telling us to send people down there? To travel from the Supreme Heaven to Spirit Heaven will require a tremendous amount of resources."

The Celestial Emperor calmly nodded, "This is not an order. I am merely requesting your help at this moment. Ten— The first ten people to accept my request will receive my support. This means you will be able to send people to Third Heaven without needing to worry about using any resources. Of course, you will be compensated for your efforts as well. Furthermore, the one to exterminate the heretic will be rewarded handsomely."

"I will do it!"

"Me too!"

Ten people raised their hands and accepted his quest immediately. In fact, over 70 percent of the people there raised their hands almost simultaneously.

The Celestial Emperor nodded with a content smile on his face, "Very well. Since everyone is so eager to assist me, I will fully support everyone here. However, since there are so many people accepting my request, we will limit each faction, family, or sect to only one person."

Sometime later, someone there asked, "Your Majesty, are there any leads to finding this heretic? Without any information on this individual, it would be impossible to find him even if all of us send our entire forces down there."

"We have a lead. Once you arrive in the Third Heaven, go speak with the Ji Family there. They should know of the situation and the identity of this person, as they were the ones who helped the Heavens become aware of his presence." The Celestial Emperor said.

The meeting continued for a few more hours until the Celestial Emperor dismissed them.

"What should we do, Lady Xu? Should we also send down someone? Even though we're not obligated to assist the Celestial Emperor, it would look bad on us and the Celestial Overlord, especially when the Evil God is involved." Senior Bai asked her.

Xu Jiaqi pondered for a moment before speaking, "There's no need for us to send anyone down there. After all, we already have someone within the Third Heaven who can help us with this matter."

"You don't mean..."

"Yes, we'll have Yuan help us exterminate this heretic. He is definitely strong enough for this task. In fact, he might even be stronger than the

people the others send down there because they have to restrict their cultivation. Meanwhile, Yuan is a Spirit King who can defeat even Spirit Sovereign."

"Then I will immediately let him—"

"There's no need to rush it. Even if the Celestial Emperor and the others hurry, they will still need some time to prepare. I will let Yuan know about the matter when we see each other again in a month." Xu Jiaqi said.

"I understand."

Shortly after the Celestial Emperor ended the meeting, several people there approached Xu Jiaqi and Senior Bai.

A cold smile appeared on Xu Jiaqi's face when she saw their faces, and she spoke in a calm voice, "If you're here to ask me about my father's legacy, you can save your breath."

These people looked at each other with perplexed faces.

"So it's true... That you've recovered your ancestor's lost legacy..."

"Let's not be so hasty, Lady Xu. I'm sure we can work something out. Even if it's just a single piece of treasure, we're willing to negotiate."

"Do you really intend on hogging the legacy all for yourself? That isn't very wise, Xu Jiaqi."

Xu Jiaqi sneered, "What I do with my father's legacy is up to me. If you want it, why don't you take it from me— if you have the capability, that is."

Chapter 1062 Lady Xiang

Chapter 1062 Lady Xiang

When the Immortals heard Xu Jiaqi's words, a look of disgust appeared on their faces, almost as though they'd accidentally swallowed a live fly.

"Hm?" Xu Jiaqi suddenly noticed a certain figure in the distance, who appeared to be leaving the place.

"Now if you'll excuse me, I have some important business to attend to." And without explaining any further, Xu Jiaqi disappeared from her spot and appeared in front of this individual she had been staring at.

"Oh~!" This individual was surprised when Xu Jiaqi appeared before her like a ghost.

"It's been a while, Lady Xiang." Xu Jiaqi said, her attitude towards this woman being the complete opposite of how she treats the others, almost as though they were friends.

"Lady Xu? You really startled me just now! I thought I was under attack or something." Lady Xiang sighed.

"Sorry, but I really needed to speak with you, and it looked like you were about to leave."

"Oh? What do you want to talk to me about?"

"Let's go somewhere more private, shall we?" Xu Jiaqi said.

Lady Xiang nodded, "I have a villa nearby. Let's go there."

Xu Jiaqi turned to look at Senior Bai and said to him, "You can return without me."

"I understand. If you need anything, call me." Senior Bai didn't want to linger around any longer due to the people there and disappeared almost immediately, almost as though he'd been teleported away.

'As I thought, she's going to get that soul cultivation technique for him... It's not going to be cheap even for someone like her...' Senior Bai sighed inwardly as the image of Lady Xiang's face appeared in his head.

Sometime later, Xu Jiaqi sat down with Lady Xiang in her villa.

"I will get straight to the point, Lady Xiang. I would like to purchase your soul cultivation technique." Xu Jiaqi said to her.

"..."

Lady Xiang slowly lowered the tea in her grasp and stared at Xu Jiaqi with a baffled look on her face.

"I'm sorry, I don't think I heard you properly just now. Can you repeat it just in case?" Lady Xiang said a moment later.

"Your soul cultivation technique. I need it."

A stiff smile appeared on Lady Xiang's face when she realized that she hadn't heard wrong just now, and she asked in a dumbfounded voice, "Why do you want my technique? And you should know that this technique isn't for sale, and even if it were for sale, it cannot be learned by just anyone. Furthermore, we both know that you're not suitable for this soul cultivation technique, so why would you want to learn it?"

"Who said anything about using it for myself? I am giving it to someone." Xu Jiaqi said.

Lady Xiang only became even more baffled after hearing such words.

"I owe him a great debt, and I promised to give him the best soul cultivation technique that I can find. If you're not willing to sell it to me, then I can only find another soul cultivation technique for him."

"This person... Is he your lover?" Lady Xiang couldn't help but ask, her eyes filled with curiosity.

"No. He's just a junior." Xu Jiaqi calmly said.

"Is that so? How boring. Anyways, I doubt this person is capable of learning my soul cultivation technique, since only someone born with immense soul strength could possibly learn it. In the entire Nine Heavens—No, in the last ten million years, only three people have been capable of learning this technique, myself being one of them."

"You won't know it until you try it. This junior... he's immensely talented and has the potential to surpass us. Please."

Lady Xiang narrowed her eyes on Xu Jiaqi, who had her head slightly lowered in a pleading manner.

"I have never seen you care so much about someone before, Lady Xu. If you tell me why you're going through all of this trouble, even lowering your head and begging me, I will consider it."

Xu Jiaqi took a deep breath and said, "I can tell you under one condition. You will not say a word about his identity to anyone. In fact, you'll act as though he doesn't even exist."

"I accept your condition."

Xu Jiaqi nodded and said, "This junior was the one who found my father's legacy—the God of War's Astral Arts. In exchange for it, I promised to give him a soul cultivation technique."

Lady Xiang raised an eyebrow after hearing this information.

"That's it? I was anticipating something more exciting... Also, he's just a junior who managed to stumble upon your ancestor's legacy. You could've

easily forced him to give you the legacy without needing to make such a promise— at least that's what most people in the gathering today would've done if they were in your shoes."

"Are you looking down on me? As if I would do something that low and despicable." Xu Jiaqi sneered.

Lady Xiang smiled, "I am just joking."

"Are you going to help me or what? I've already lowered my head for you. If you think I will do it for a second time..."

A serious expression appeared on Lady Xiang's face as she spoke, "Since we're friends and I do owe you a favor, I will give this junior a chance to learn my soul cultivation technique. However, this doesn't mean it will be free. Whether or not this junior is capable of learning the technique or not, you'll still have to pay."

"How much do you want?" Xu Jiaqi asked.

"Who said anything about money? I want you to do something for me." A cold smile appeared on Lady Xiang's face.

Xu Jiaqi frowned, "What are you plotting?"

"You see, a certain group of people have been harassing me and my family recently. I'm sure you've heard about them. I would love to deal with them myself, but I do not have the capability. If you want me to give this junior a chance to learn my soul cultivation technique, you will have to help me 'deal with' these people. Do you understand what I am saying?"

The frown on Xu Jiaqi's face deepened.

"You want me to destroy the Sky Whales faction?" she mumbled in a dumbfounded voice.

Chapter 1063 Limitless Bloodlust

Chapter 1063 Limitless Bloodlust

"The Sky Whales faction is a top 50 faction in the entire Nine Heavens, not to mention that within their alliance there is a top 10 faction. I cannot attack them without any reasons, especially considering my faction's reputation. You're asking for the impossible." Xu Jiaqi said with a deep frown on her face.

"I am well aware of your faction's reputation. Celestial Overlord, the number one righteous faction in the nine heavens and also a top 3 faction. However, who said anything about attacking the Sky Whales faction without a reason? If you want a reason, I will give you one. The current leader of the Sky Whales faction Immortal Tongshi, is actually a heretic— a Demon Worshiper."

"What?!" Xu Jiaqi's eyes widened with shock.

"Where did you get that information? I swear, if you're lying to convince me to attack them..."

"If you don't believe me, go investigate it yourself. I will even give you my sources. Also, have you forgotten my identity? Do you think I would lie to you about something like this?"

Xu Jiaqi narrowed her eyes and pondered, 'If it's true— that Immortal Tongshi is a Demon Worshiper, we have all the right to execute him.'

"I will let you know my decision in a week after I am finished with my investigation." Xu Jiaqi said a moment later.

"Take all the time you need." Lady Xiang smiled.

Xu Jiaqi left the villa shortly after.

Meanwhile, Yuan looked through the fifth floor of the Myriad of Technique after returning.

Most of the techniques on the fifth floor were Divine-rank cultivation techniques, and although there were a few interesting ones, none of them were really appealing enough for him to learn.

After looking through all of the techniques, Yuan met up with Meixiu and the others.

"Did you guys find anything you like?" He asked.

"I didn't." Chu Liuxiang shook her head, and she continued, "I am still learning the techniques I acquired the last time we came here. Also, none of the techniques here suit me."

"Me too." Meixiu said.

"Um... I found one that I like, but it's a Divine-rank technique..." Li Jinxi said.

"Oh? What kind of technique is it?" Yuan asked, his interest piqued.

"It's called Limitless Bloodlust. It allows me to grow stronger with every magical beast that I kill. I think this is a very fitting technique for me." She said.

"Oh? That sounds very similar to my innate ability that allows me to grow stronger as I consume my enemies." Lan Yingying said.

"Indeed, and it's the perfect technique for someone like you." Yuan smiled.

"If there's nothing else, let's check out." He then said.

Sometime later, they went to pay for the Li Jinxi's technique.

"This technique will cost you 70 million spirit stones." The young man behind the desk said.

"70 million spirit stones..." Yuan's eyebrows twitched when he heard the price tag.

'I have underestimated the price of a Divine-rank technique! However, even if it's a Divine-rank technique, isn't it a little too expensive?' Yuan wondered to himself.

When the young man saw Yuan's frozen expression, he smiled and explained, "This technique may be a Divine-rank technique, but its potential is actually closer to Ancient-rank, hence why it's so much more expensive than the average Divine-rank technique."

"70 million spirit stones is too much, Yuan. I appreciate the thought, but I cannot let you spend that much money on me." Li Jinxi said with a bittersweet smile on her face.

Clearly, she liked the technique very much and would be disappointed to not acquire it, but she didn't want to be unreasonable, nor could she afford it by herself.

Feng Yuxiang glanced at Li Jinx for a second before speaking, "I'll pay for it."

"Eh?" Everyone there turned to look at her.

"Why would you...?" Li Jinxi asked with a puzzled look on her face.

"You're my Young Master's precious friend, and I cannot allow him to lose face over something like this." Feng Yuxiang said with her body emanating a prideful aura.

Yuan didn't object to this and said, "I will pay you back as soon as possible, Feng Feng."

After all, he also believed that this technique would benefit Li Jinxi greatly and wanted her to have it.

Sometime later, Feng Yuxiang paid 70 million spirit stones to the young man.

After counting it, he handed the technique over to Li Jinxi.

"Good luck."

"Thank you, Madam Feng, thank you, Yuan. I will not forget this debt." Li Jinxi bowed to them after they left the Myriad of Techniques.

"Don't mention it." Feng Yuxiang smiled.

"What are we going to do now, Yuan?" Chu Liuxiang asked him.

"I am going to visit Tian Chenyu's old home," he said.

"If you don't mind, I want to cultivate this new technique." Li Jinxi suddenly said, as she could barely hold her excitement.

Yuan nodded, "Sure. I'm sure there's a Cultivators' Haven in this city. Let's stop by that place first then."

After asking for directions, they went straight to the Cultivators' Haven.

Yuan helped Li Jinxi pay for their best room.

"Yuan, I would also like to cultivate by myself for a while." Meixiu suddenly said, "I have been ignoring my cultivation in this world for a while now, and I don't want to be too far behind and become a burden."

When she heard Meixiu's words, Chu Liuxiang also decided to stay behind, "Then I will stay as well."

"I don't mind. How long do you guys want to cultivate?" Yuan asked them.

"How does two weeks sound?" Li Jinxi said.

"Alright. Then I will come get you guys in two weeks." Yuan nodded.

In the end, he rented three of the best rooms in the Cultivators' Haven for 2 weeks.

"See you in two weeks, Yuan." The ladies said to him before going into their respective rooms to cultivate.

"I'll see you guys later." Yuan left the Cultivators' Haven shortly after.

"Now then, let's go visit my old home, shall we?" A smile appeared on Yuan's face as he began approaching Tian Chenyu's home.

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Chapter 1064 Tian Family

Chapter 1064 Tian Family

After leaving Meixiu and the others in the Cultivators' Haven to train, Yuan made his way to Tian Chenyu's home.

However, he quickly realized a problem.

'It's been millions of years since then, and this city clearly has gone through many changes. The chances of my old home being in the same location is probably zero...'

After pondering for some time, Yuan decided to check the place just in case it was still there.

Sometime later, he arrived at the location of Tian Chenyu's home— or where it was supposed to be.

However, it was quickly made clear to Yuan that his home no longer existed. This location that used to be Tian Chenyu's home has been replaced by a restaurant.

Yuan sighed, "I knew it was pointless. After all, millions of years have passed since Tian Chenyu's era. There's no way his home would still be here after so long."

"Don't give up, Brother Yuan." Xiao Hua said to him.

He smiled, "You're right. I shouldn't give up so quickly."

He approached the restaurant a moment later.

"Welcome to the Heavenly Restaurant. How many guests?" The waitress at the front asked when they entered the building.

"Hello, this may be sudden, but I have a question. Do you know anything about the Tian Family that used to live here? If my memories serve me right, this place used to be their home." Yuan asked the waitress with a handsome smile on his face, which made it hard for her to refuse.

"Yes, I know of the Tian Family. In fact, they are the owners of this restaurant." The waitress said a moment later.

"Really?! Where can I find them? I would like to speak with them!"

"Um... What relationship do you have with the Tian Family? They're not really friendly with strangers." The waitress asked him.

"Our ancestors knew each other, and my ancestor owed the Tian Family a favor, so I am going to return that favor in my ancestor's stead." Yuan calmly said.

"If that's the case... Let me give you the Tian Family's current address." The waitress nodded.

Sometime later, Yuan left the restaurant and went to the location given to him by the waitress.

"So this is where the Tian Family of this generation resides..." Yuan mumbled to himself as he stood before the residence of the Tian Family.

The building looked nothing like the one in his memories, but he still felt a nostalgic feeling from it for some reason, almost as though he instinctively knew he belonged here.

He approached the front doors and knocked on it with Xiao Hua by his side.

A few moments later, an old woman opened the doors and stepped outside.

"What do you want?" The old lady had an unfriendly aura around her, and she looked a little angry for some reason.

"If you're from the Lin Family, then you can turn around because the Young Lady won't see any of you!"

Yuan raised an eyebrow at her behavior, but he remained calm and spoke, "I think there's been a misunderstanding. I am here on behalf of my ancestor, who owes a great debt to the Tian Family."

The old lady sneered at his words and said, "That's the worst excuse so far. Even a dog could come up with a better story than you! Now scram, dogs from the Lin Family!"

"Eh? But I am not from the Lin Family. Tian Chenyu, do you know of this name?" Yuan said with a stiff smile on his face.

"Tian Chenyu?!" The old lady's eyes widened with shock.

"H-How do you know of this name?! Who are you?!"

"I apologize for the late introduction. My name is Yuan. I have recently learned that my ancestors owed a great debt to the Tian Family, but he was unable to repay that debt before he passed away, so I came here to repay his debt for him. If there's anything I can do for the Tian Family, don't hesitate to ask me."

Since they were technically his family and Tian Chenyu never really got the chance to help his family, as he was too busy dealing with demons, Yuan decided to assist the Tian Family instead.

"Please wait here for a minute. Since I am just a caretaker, I cannot let you in by myself. I will go speak with the head of the family right now." The old lady bowed to Yuan before closing the door.

Yuan proceeded to wait outside.

Meanwhile, inside the residence, the old lady walked past a bronze statue in the middle of the garden to speak with a middle-aged man.

"What? Someone is here to return a debt?" The middle-aged man raised his eyebrows after hearing this.

"Yes, and he claims that his ancestors knew our ancestors."

"How foolish. Do you really believe that? He's probably using that as an excuse to intrude on our family. Let him be." The middle-aged man casually waved his hand.

"But he knew the name of our ancestor, Tian Chenyu..." The old lady saved this information for last.

"What?! Why didn't you say this sooner?! Nobody outside the family should know his name! And since we've all taken an oath to never reveal this name to anybody outside the family, there's no way an outsider would know about it!"

Although most people in the Nine Heavens forgot about Tian Chenyu's name, the Tian Family never forgot it. In fact, Tian Chenyu's family made it so that all descendants are required to remember this name and pass it down to their children, which has become their tradition.

However, they also made everyone swear an oath to never reveal Tian Chenyu's real identity to outsiders or they would die a horrible death.

The middle-aged man and the old lady left the room shortly after.

Sometime later, they brought Yuan and Xiao Hua into their residence.

Once they were all seated, the middle-aged man said to the old lady, "Go bring us some tea."

"I understand." The old lady bowed to them before leaving the room.

Chapter 1065 Tian Family(2)

Chapter 1065 Tian Family(2)

Once the old lady left, the middle-aged man turned to look at Yuan and continued, "My name is Tian Xianzu, the head of this humble family."

"May I know your background and what you know about the name Tian Chenyu?" Tian Xianzu asked him with a friendly smile.

He nodded, and said, "Honestly, I don't know much about Tian Chenyu. I only learned of this name in a note left behind by one of my ancestors. I also don't know how long ago this note was written, but I firmly believe that no matter how much time passes, a debt will never go away on its own."

Tian Xianzu pondered for a moment before asking, "Do you know how your ancestor became indebted to our ancestor?"

"I don't."

"Then do you have the note with you?"

"Unfortunately, the note is very fragile and on the verge of breakdown, so I didn't dare to bring it with me."

"Hmm..." Tian Xianzu narrowed his eyes slightly with a pondering look on his face.

It was obvious that he didn't fully trust Yuan, as his story sounded a little too convenient and suspicious.

"The tea is ready." The old lady returned with the tea.

After pouring all of them a cup, she left the teapot on the table.

"Bring my daughter here." Tian Xianzu suddenly said to the old lady.

"The Young Lady...?" The old lady seemed hesitant, her reason being the same as Tian Xianzu's reason.

"Yes."

"I understand."

The old lady left again.

'I will decide if we can trust him after I see his reaction to my daughter.'
Tian Xianzu thought to himself.

He was thinking that if Yuan had any interior motives, he would see it the moment Yuan meets with his daughter.

Yuan casually sipped on the tea and didn't utter a single word for the next few minutes.

He understood their situation— that the Tian Family was having doubts about his identity, which he couldn't blame because they were right to doubt someone as suspicious as him.

In fact, he would also be suspicious if he were in their shoes, and if he speaks or tries to convince them that he's not there to harm them, that would only make him more suspicious.

Sometime later, Yuan could hear two sets of footsteps approaching the room.

A few moments later, a beautiful young lady who looked to be a little older than Yuan entered the room.

She had a tall and slender figure. Her hair was pitch black and tied into a hair bun behind her head. Her face looked gentle yet fierce at the same time, and her clear brown eyes shone with brightness.

"..."

Xiao Hua and the other two inside Yuan's body were surprised when they saw this young woman, but it was not because of her beauty.

No, they were surprised by her facial features that resembled Yuan but looked way more feminine, almost as though she was Yuan's twin sister.

In fact, with the help of makeup, Yuan could definitely become this young woman and vice versa.

However, just like Tian Xianzu, Yuan didn't notice their resemblance.

"Let me introduce you to my daughter, Tian Yanyu. Yanyu, this is our guest, Yuan."

"Hello." She gave him a courteous nod.

"It's nice to meet you. I'm Yuan, and I came here to repay a debt that my ancestors owed to your family. If there's anything you need help with, don't hesitate to let me know." Yuan said to her with a gentle smile on his face.

"..."

Tian Yanyu clearly wasn't expecting such a reason for his visit, but she didn't complain.

After a moment of silence, she spoke again, "You'll help us with anything?"

Yuan nodded, "As long as it's within my power, I will do my best to help you."

A cold look suddenly appeared on Tian Yanyu's face as she spoke, "Then help me erase the Lin Family from this world."

"Yanyu!" Tian Xianzu immediately frowned at her words.

"The Lin Family? The first time I've heard about them is when your caretaker mistook me for them. Who are they? And what have they done to

deserve this punishment?" Yuan asked her.

"You've never heard of the Lin Family? How is that possible? They're one of the biggest families in this world— They're one of the Seven Legacy Families!" The old lady exclaimed.

"Actually, I'm not from around this area, but I have heard of the Seven Legacy Families." Yuan said.

"The Lin Family has been harassing and bullying my family for the last four years because I refused to become their oldest son's woman." Tian Yanyu said with a disgusted look on her face.

'So it's that kind of situation, huh...' Yuan sighed inwardly.

"So can you help us or not? If you can't, then we don't need your help at all." Tian Yanyu stared at him with slightly narrowed eyes.

Yuan didn't immediately respond and began pondering.

"You don't have to mind her unreasonable request, Yuan. Although it's true that the Lin Family has been harassing us, there's nothing we can do about it."

Yuan sighed out loud before speaking, "It's fine. I don't mind it."

He turned to look at Tian Yanyu and continued, "I don't mind helping you with the Lin Family, but I cannot do something like slaughter them— not because I don't have the power to. I am just not fond of unnecessary bloodshed."

The Tian Family's eyes widened with shock after they heard Yuan's words, mostly because he casually claimed that he had the power to destroy the Lin Family.

"How about this? I will get the Lin Family to stop harassing your family and stop pestering you. Would that be helpful enough?" Yuan said as he looked directly at Tian Yanyu.

"I-If you can really do that..." Tian Yanyu nodded in a dazed manner, as she didn't really expect him to agree to her request.

After all, they were going against one of the Seven Legacy Families, an untouchable force for most people.

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Chapter 1066 Tian Family(3)

Chapter 1066 Tian Family(3)

"W-Wait a minute!" Tian Xianzu suddenly said.

"What's wrong?" Yuan asked.

"This is ridiculous! You want to go against the Lin Family, one of the Seven Legacy Families?! I appreciate your willingness to help us, but that's too much! You're not only going to get yourself killed, but you're also going to drag our Tian Family along with you to the grave!" Tian Xianzu exclaimed.

He turned to look at Tian Yanyu and continued, "You too! Stop your nonsense! The moment we lay a finger on the Lin Family, they will completely destroy us! The only reason they don't dare to touch our family right now is because of our family history! However, if we give them a reason to act, they will move in full force!"

"Are you telling me to sit still and stay silent while they continue to harass our family?! Our restaurant's business has gone down 90 percent since last year because of the Lin Family's cowardly antics! If this continues any longer, our Tian Family will be reduced to nothing, regardless if we touch them or not! And I am not going down without a fight!" Tian Yanyu remained resilient.

"You—!" Tian Xianzu didn't know what else to say after hearing his daughter's words.

"Let's all calm down, shall we?" Yuan suddenly said, still looking as relaxed as ever.

"The Lin Family may be one of Seven Legacy Families, but they are not untouchable. Why don't you tell me a little more about your situation?"

Tian Yanyu nodded and took a seat at the table.

"I will get another teacup." The old lady said before leaving the room.

Once she was seated, Tian Yanyu spoke, "It started four years ago when I first met Lin Minghai on the stage during a friendly competition between our sects. I managed to narrowly defeat him, and the very next day, he would begin courting me. Of course, I refused. However, he would continue to court me persistently over the next several days. Eventually, days turned into weeks, and weeks turned into months. It's been four years since then, but he's still courting me."

"He was just being annoying at first, but as time passed, he would become more aggressive, and he would also start scheming by spreading bad rumors about me so that others would stay away from me. Then he started targeting our family businesses. We used to own several restaurants throughout the city, but we had to close down most of them because the Lin Family would send thugs to cause drama in our restaurants and mess with our reputation, forcing us to close them down. Now we're down to just one restaurant."

"Of course, we can't do anything about it because we don't have concrete proof that the Lin Family is behind these incidents, but there's no way it's all just a coincidence. Lin Minghai even personally came to our house before, and he told my father that he would help us deal with the thugs, acting like he is innocent."

Yuan listened to Tian Yanyu explained their situation in detail with a tranquil expression on his face, but he was inwardly annoyed at the Lin Family and their nature.

"How typical. The powerful and influential tyrants are abusing their power and oppressing the weak to achieve their goals. This is quite common in the cultivation world. These people are a waste of spiritual energy. We should just kill everyone in the Lin Family and get this over with." Feng Yuxiang snorted.

"Have you forgotten about our situation, Feng Feng? We're already being hunted by the Seven Legacy Families and the Ji Family. If we do something like that, they will be all over us." Yuan said.

"We're already hunted, so it wouldn't make any difference. In fact, we should be the ones to strike first! They tried to ambush us outside the Stairway to Heaven, so it would only be fair if we ambushed one of them in return!"

"Let's not make our situation any more complicated than it already is. If we can solve this without shedding too much blood, that would be ideal." Yuan shook his head inwardly.

Once she finished explaining, Tian Yanyu asked, "What do you think? Can you help us?" Read latest chapters at FreeWebnovel.com Only.

Yuan pondered for a moment before speaking, "Are the thugs still an issue?"

"Yes, they come to our restaurant once a week to cause trouble for the customers, sometimes more."

"Then we will start by dealing with the thugs. The Lin Family won't be able to do anything unless they want to reveal that they're with the thugs." Yuan said.

"That sounds reasonable. But how are we going to do that?" Tian Yanyu asked him.

"It's quite simple, actually. I am going to visit your restaurant as a customer, and if they pick a fight with me, I will deal with them accordingly." Yuan said with a smile.

"You make it sound so easy... but will it really work out as it does in your head?"

He nodded, "Of course. They're working for the Lin Family and you're their target, right? If you visit the restaurant with me, they will, without a doubt,

try to mess with us."

Bang!

Tian Xianzu suddenly slammed the table.

"Wait! You want my daughter to be bait?! I am against her involvement in your nonsense!"

"Well, I don't really need her help, but it will make things move quicker."

"I will do it." Tian Yanyu said.

"Yanyu!"

"You say you don't want my involvement, but I am already involved—I have been since the beginning. And like Yuan said, the Lin Family won't be able to do anything to us unless they want to expose themselves." Tian Yanyu said.

"That may be true, but they will still know that you're trying to fight back against them! I don't want anything to happen to you!"

"Don't worry, I will protect her." Yuan suddenly said.

Tian Yanyu turned to look at Yuan and smiled, "Don't look down on me. I am not so weak that I need your protection. If it wasn't for his background, I would've already taken care of Lin Minghai by myself."

"Good." He smiled.

Chapter 1067 Tian Family(4)

Chapter 1067 Tian Family(4)

"A-Are you seriously going to do this?" Tian Xianzu was still feeling concerned about this whole situation.

In his eyes, a stranger that they haven't known for even half a day suddenly told them that he would help them take care of the Lin Family, one of the Seven Legacy Families. If it were anybody else, they would have already kicked Yuan out. However, for some reason, neither Tian Xianzu nor Tian Yanyu doubted him.

"Trust me, if anything goes wrong, you won't have to take the blame, as I will take the blame for myself." Yuan comforted him with a confident smile.

"Why are you so confident? This is the Seven Legacy Families we're talking about. It's like messing with a bee hive. Anger one bee and you'll anger the other bees as well. In this case, that would be the other six Legacy Families." Tian Xianzu asked him.

Yuan smiled, "It's not my first time dealing with them."

"Eh?"

Both Tian Xianzu and Tian Yanyu's eyes widened with surprise after hearing such words.

'Not his first time dealing with them? What does he mean by that...?' They wondered inwardly.

"Anyways, before we deal with the thugs, I would like to say one more thing. To make this safer for all of us, let's not call me Yuan when we are outside. Let's see..."

Yuan began pondering for a name.

'I wanted to use Tian Yang for my fake identity, but it wouldn't be wise to associate myself with the Tian Family with what we're going to do, especially if things go south.'

Yuan suddenly noticed Xiao Hua sitting beside him and turned to look at her with a pondering face.

Noticing his glare, Xiao Hua turned to look at him with a puzzled face.

A smile appeared on Yuan's face as he spoke, "Whenever we're outside, please address me as Xiao Yang."

"Eh?" Xiao Hua's eyes widened with shock.

"Do you mind? If you do, I can use another surname." Yuan said.

"Use mine, Young Master!" Feng Feng said.

"I-It's okay. Brother Yuan can use it." Xiao Hua nodded.

Due to the history associated with her family's background, it would be quite foolish to take the Asura Clan's surname, perhaps even courting death. However, since they're only in Third Heaven, where nobody would recognize this surname, it was fine.

"T-Then we'll be in your care, Xiao Yang." Tian Yanyu said to him a moment later.

Sometime later, Yuan and Tian Yanyu left the Tian Family's household and made their way to the Heavenly Restaurant.

"I hope nothing happens to them..." The old lady sighed.

"Let's not jinx it... And have some of our guards secretly follow them. If anything happens, I want them to immediately report it."

"As you wish— Oh... Should I also notify Madam?"

"...No, not yet."

"I understand."

When Yuan and Tian Yanyu arrived at the Heavenly Restaurant, Tian Yanyu asked, "Where do you want to sit, Xiao Yang?"

"Anywhere is fine."

"Alright."

Tian Yanyu then said to the waitress, "Give us the best table."

"I understand, Young Lady."

The waitress recognized Yuan and glanced at him again before leading them to their table.

Once they were seated, Tian Yanyu said, "Order whatever you want. It's in the house."

Yuan nodded and looked through the menu before ordering the dishes that intrigued him the most. Since he was expecting there to be trouble, he didn't want to order too much food and waste them in the end.

Once the waitress got their orders, she left them alone.

"By the way, I should have said this sooner, but if you're going to hide your identity, wouldn't it be wiser if you disguised your face as well?"

"Now that you mention it... Oh, but we don't have any pills for disguise."

"Young Master, if you want, I can concoct you one right now." Feng Yuxiang suddenly said.

"Thank you, but it's a little too late for that since everyone here has already seen my face, not to mention the people that had been following us since we left the Tian Family."

"I understand."

"Hey." Tian Yanyu suddenly spoke, "Can you tell me about yourself? What did you do before you came here? Are you a disciple? If so, what sect? What motivated you to help us?"

"Before coming here, huh? I guess I was just wandering the world. I used to be in a sect but not anymore. As for my motivation... It may sound foolish, but I really don't like owing debt to anyone, even if this debt is technically my ancestor's responsibility." Yuan said.

"You left the sect...? Or did you get kicked out for causing trouble?" Tian Yanyu seemed to be intrigued about his sect.

"Of course not. I left my sect on good terms. In the first place, I joined them because I needed to gain some experience, as I lived a secluded life before I joined the sect."

"Is that so..." Tian Yanyu stared at his face with a pondering look on her face.

"I understand your feeling of not wanting to owe any debts, but I don't know if I would go as far as repaying a debt that my ancestors owed millions of years ago. You're a silly one, Yu— Xiao Yang."

Yuan chuckled, "I get that a lot."

"But I don't hate it. In fact, I kind of admire your passion." She suddenly added.

"Thank—"

Yuan suddenly halted his mouth when he sensed killing intent directed in his direction.

"What's wrong?" Tian Yanyu asked him when she saw his actions.

"They're here earlier than I thought. We haven't even gotten our first dish yet and they're already looking for a fight." He showed a cold smile on his face.

"You don't mean..."

"Waow! Look what we have here! If it isn't the Young Lady! Did the sun rise from the west today or something? How unusual to see you here!" A deep voice suddenly boomed inside the restaurant, causing everyone there to look at the source.

Yuan casually turned his head to see a group of hooligans wearing bandit-like clothes and with faces that looked like they were asking for trouble approaching their table.

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Chapter 1068 A Group of Hooligans

Chapter 1068 A Group of Hooligans

"Hey, hey, hey! Young Lady! Why are you sharing a table with another man? Are you cheating on Young Master Lin Minghai already?!" This group of troublemakers approached the table with wide smiles on their faces.

"Young Master Lin Minghai will be heartbroken when he learns of this!"

"Hey, brat! Who are you? Do you know whose woman you are messing with?!"

"..."

Tian Yanyu didn't say anything, and her gaze remained on Yuan the whole time, as she didn't want to miss any of his movements.

'Now, what are you going to do, Yuan? If you cannot even handle a few hooligans, the Lin Family will definitely be out of your reach.' She pondered inwardly.

Yuan casually turned to look at the hooligans and spoke in a calm voice, "I'm sorry, but I wasn't expecting any more guests. Also, when was the last time you guys changed clothes? You all smell like rotten eggs and dog feces together. I would appreciate it if you can be more considerate to others, especially since we're inside a restaurant where people come to eat."

"Y-You bastard..."

The hooligans' faces flushed with redness after hearing Yuan's insults, and their bodies trembled uncontrollably.

However, before they could even utter a single word, Yuan continued to speak, "My food will be here soon. If you're not gone by then, don't blame me for being rude."

"Oh? And what the fuck are you going to do if we don't leave?" The hooligan leading the group asked Yuan with a malicious grin on his face.

"Feng Feng, I don't want their blood to dirty the place I am going to eat at. Can you deal with it without making a mess? Oh, leave one of them alive." Yuan suddenly said in a low voice.

"It would be my pleasure, Young Master."

Several orbs of flames suddenly emerged from Yuan's body and flew towards the group of hooligans, and before they could even react, their bodies were immediately engulfed with flames.

In less than a second, all but one of the hooligans were burnt until there was nothing left of them, leaving behind no mess or blood.

Everyone in the restaurant was shocked by what they had just witnessed, but they were also puzzled, as they couldn't comprehend the situation.

After Feng Yuxiang killed most of the hooligans, Yuan turned to look at the last one and asked in a calm voice, "Who hired you to mess with the Tian Family? If you don't speak truthfully, you will end up just like your friends — erased."

"I-I don't know! I swear! I am just a lowly lackey following orders! Please, you have to believe me!" The young man got on his knees and begged Yuan.

"Then tell me about your order." Yuan then said.

"Yes! We, the Stone Bandits, were hired to disturb the Tian Family's businesses until they shut down!"

"And you don't know who hired you?"

"No!"

"Then who does?"

"That would be the leaders!"

"And where can I find these leaders?"

"T-That's..." The young bandit hesitated to answer this question, as he would also be killed by his peers for revealing the location of their base.

"If you tell me, I will not only let you live, but I will even make sure the Stone Bandits won't be able to harm you. A pretty good deal, don't you think so?" Yuan said.

"I-I am willing to tell you." The young bandit nodded after a moment of silence.

Since he was going to die either way, he might as well accept Yuan's request that will, at the very least, give him a chance to survive.

"Very well. You can bring me to your hideout after we're done eating here. Until then, go wait outside. I wasn't joking when I said that you all stink." Yuan said.

"I-I understand!" The young bandit immediately jumped to his feet, but before he could go anywhere, Yuan's voice resounded again.

"Oh, right. One more thing. If you're thinking about running away, you will immediately be killed. My divine sense covers a good chunk of this city, so unless you can outrun my divine sense, I suggest you stay put and wait for us. Do you understand?"

"I-I wouldn't dare to run away from you!" The young bandit vigorously nodded his head.

"Good. Then I will see you in a bit."

The young bandit quickly scrambled out of the restaurant, but he didn't dare to wander too far away from the restaurant, as he feared that Yuan might mistake it as escaping.

And for the next hour, this young bandit wouldn't move a single step from this location, almost as if he'd turned into a stone statue.

"You... What was that just now?" Tian Yanyu asked him with an astonished look on her face after the bandit left.

"What? Are you not happy with the way I handled it?" Yuan raised an eyebrow.

"No, that's not it... Forget it. I didn't think you would resort to violence so quickly, especially after what you said about not wanting to shed unnecessary blood."

"I don't, hence why I killed them without spilling any blood." Yuan said with a joking smile on his face.

"I'm just joking. They are just a bunch of bandits who have been causing trouble for your family and countless other people for years. Nobody will care if I clean up some trash. Of course, if the Lin Family is willing to go to war over those hooligans, that would be a different story."

"Your appearance is quite deceptive, as you are more daring than your appearance suggests." Tian Yanyu mumbled with a slight smile on her face.

The waitress approached their table with their food a few minutes later, and they began eating the food shortly after, acting as though the whole situation with the hooligans just now didn't even happen.

Once they were finished, Yuan and the other two went outside to meet with the young bandit again.

"Alright. Bring me to your hideout." Yuan said.

"Yes!" The young bandit answered without hesitation.

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Chapter 1069 Stone Bandits' Hideout

Chapter 1069 Stone Bandits' Hideout

"Hey, it might be a bit dangerous, so if you want, you can return home for now and wait for me to finish." Yuan said to Tian Yanyu, who immediately frowned upon hearing his words.

"Are you still looking down on me? I told you that I can handle myself, right? If I turn out to be a burden, you can leave me alone to die because I will deserve it."

"Leave you to die...? You know very well I can't do that." Yuan said with a bittersweet smile.

"Alright, if you want to follow me, go ahead."

Tian Yanyu was a peak Spirit Lord despite her seemingly young age, so she could be considered quite talented for this world's standard.

Of course, since Yuan was suppressing his spiritual energy, Tian Yanyu was unaware of Yuan's cultivation as a peak Spirit King.

With that being said, Yuan didn't bother suppressing his aura, so she knew that he was a formidable individual— at least that's what her instincts and experience told her.

Compared to her fellow disciples, Yuan was multiple times more powerful.

Sometime later, the young bandit led Yuan and Tian Yanyu to this large building.

"We're here, Young Master." The young bandit said to Yuan, who had his eyebrows raised.

Meanwhile, Tian Yanyu had a deep frown on her face.

"Are you mocking us right now?" Tian Yanyu muttered in a cold voice.

The building itself wasn't the problem; it was the environment and the situation outside of this place that made Tian Yanyu furious.

There were multiple women wearing heavy makeup and revealing clothes standing outside this building, and they were all glaring at Yuan like foxes.

It was clear what kind of purpose this place served, and the only person there that didn't understand the situation was Xiao Hua, who was too innocent to know about these kinds of things.

"I-I am most certainly not mocking you, Young Lady! This is truly the Stone Bandits' hideout! They have been operating this entertainment business for over 50 years now!" The young bandit quickly said, trying his best to defend himself.

"This is certainly a surprise." Yuan mumbled out loud, "When you hear about bandits, you normally associate them with the wilderness. This is the first time I've heard of bandits hiding within the city, acting like gangsters instead."

The young bandit then spoke, "I don't know the Stone Bandits' leader's name, but he should have a pretty high standing in this place."

"What should we do?" Yuan turned to look at Tian Yanyu, who was glaring at the building with a disgusted look on her face, as she hated the concept of women selling their bodies for money.

However, before she could respond, the workers at this building approached them with bright smiles on their faces.

"Handsome, are you new here? I have never seen you before, and I would never forget a face as handsome as yours."

"How would you like to spend the day with me? Not only will I give you special service, but I won't even charge you a single copper."

"Is this your girlfriend here? I won't mind even if she joins us..."

These women quickly surrounded Yuan. However, when they got too close, a burst of flame suddenly erupted from Yuan's body.

"Young Master, should I just burn this whole place to the ground and call it a day?" Feng Yuxiang's voice resounded the following moment.

"There's no need to be so upset. They're just trying to do their jobs." Yuan shook his head inwardly.

He then said to the ladies, "Sorry about that just now. We are actually here to see your boss. Is he available right now?"

"Our boss...?" The ladies exchanged glances with each other.

"Do you have an appointment? The boss doesn't meet with anyone that doesn't have one." One of them said.

"We do. Tell your boss that Tian Yanyu is here for her appointment." Tian Yanyu suddenly said.

"I understand. I will go tell my manager."

One of the ladies went into the building while the others went to speak with other nearby pedestrians.

"Tian Yanyu? There's nobody with that name on the appointment list." The manager said after hearing the woman's words.

"Really? That's what she told me, though." The woman said.

"She's probably just another ordinary whore trying to get a job at our Passion Palace. Ignore them."

"I don't think that's the case... That woman was really beautiful and looked nothing like one of us, and she had a handsome young man and a child with her."

"It doesn't change the fact that they're not on the appointment list and that they'd lied to you. Ignore them!" The manager exclaimed.

"I understand..."

Sometime later, Yuan said, "It's been a while since that woman went inside."

Tian Yanyu sucked her teeth, "They probably realized that we didn't have an appointment, or they're just trying to ignore us."

"What are you going to do now?" She then asked.

"If they want to ignore us, we will do the opposite and force them to acknowledge us." Yuan said.

He turned to look at the young bandit and said to him, "Bring us to your boss."

"Y-Yes..." The young bandit wanted to cry, but he had no choice but to obey Yuan's words.

The young bandit proceeded to lead Yuan and the others inside the building.

"Welcome to the Passion Palace! What kind of entertainment are you looking for—" The worker at the front desk stopped speaking when he noticed Xiao Hua's figure.

"I'm sorry, but this place isn't appropriate for children..."

Yuan glanced at Xiao Hua and cleared his throat, "Sorry, but we're not here to have fun."

He turned to look at the young bandit and continued, "Go tell your boss he has three minutes to show up before I blow up this entire place."

Naturally, Yuan was only bluffing, but the young bandit and the others didn't know that.

"R-Right away!" The young bandit immediately disappeared from their sight.

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Chapter 1070 Stone Bandits' Hideout(2)

Chapter 1070 Stone Bandits' Hideout(2)

"Y-You! Who are you?! Do you know where you are?! How dare you cause a commotion here!" The manager of the Passion Palace showed up shortly after Yuan entered the building with Tian Yanyu.

Yuan glanced at the middle-aged man, who had a furious face, and said, "If you had brought us to your boss in the first place, we wouldn't have needed to resort to this."

"Guards! Throw them out of here!" The manager shouted, and over a dozen Spirit Lord cultivators surrounded them the next moment.

"Are you aware that this place is being run by the Stone Bandits?" Tian Yanyu asked them in a calm voice.

And she continued, "If you are aware of this fact and still decided to help them, we have the authority to kill you all. This is your last chance to walk away."

Tian Yanyu retrieved an elegant sword with a thin blade and casually swung it at the empty air in front of her.

"Stone Bandits?! That is a baseless accusation! What proof do you have that this place is run by these bandits?!" The manager exclaimed.

"I have worked in this place for over 30 years and I have never seen anything related to those bandits from this place!"

Tian Yanyu smiled and said, "To not notice something like this after so long, you must be blind, but that's not even the worst part. If you've worked here for over 30 years and do not know about the Stone Bandits, that must mean they don't trust you enough to tell you about it despite the amount of time you have spent here."

The manager trembled in anger after hearing such words, and he roared, "They're just spewing nonsense to mess with our heads! This place isn't run by any bandits! Kill them!"

"Yes!"

The guards shouted as they encircled Yuan and his small group.

"Don't say I didn't warn you!" Tian Yanyu said as she went into an offensive position.

However, before the guards or Tian Yanyu could move, Yuan suddenly activated Heavenly Domain, instantly overwhelming the guards and forcing them to their knees without seriously injuring them.

"Let's all just calm down and wait for the boss to show up, shall we?" Yuan spoke with a nonchalant expression on his face.

Even though the guards couldn't see Yuan's cultivation, they instinctively knew that he was not someone to be trifled with, so they all remained on their knees with their heads lowered even after the Heavenly Domain was deactivated.

Meanwhile, somewhere inside the building, the young bandit was kowtowing before a bulky bald man, who had an enraged expression on his face.

"So you failed your mission and even brought trouble back to our hideout, huh? I knew you were trouble since the day we accepted you. I should've killed you sooner..." The bulky man suddenly jumped out of his bed, where several naked women were resting, and landed in front of the young bandit.

"I hope you're prepared for your punishment, young one..."

However, the young bandit immediately jumped to his feet and rushed outside.

"You think you can run away?!" The bulky man got dressed in less than a second and chased after the young bandit, who didn't dare to look back as he rushed back to Yuan and Tian Yanyu.

"Young Master! I brought the boss here!" The young bandit shouted even before he could see Yuan's face again.

"Die, you useless trash!" The bulky man had caught up to the young bandit and prepared to strike him.

However, before his fist could reach the young bandit, a figure appeared between them and causally blocked his fist.

"So you're the Stone Bandits' leader? I have a few questions for you." Yuan calmly spoke as he stood before the bulky man like an immovable mountain.

"W-Who the fuck are you? Stone Bandits? I have no idea what you're talking about." The bulky man was greatly surprised by Yuan's sudden appearance and was even a little nervous.

Even though he didn't go all out for his strike, it was still enough to kill a Spirit Lord with ease, yet Yuan had managed to block it with one hand and with seemingly no effort at all.

"So you're not affiliated with the hooligans that have been causing trouble for the Tian Family?" Yuan asked.

The bulky man retrieved his fist and spoke, "Tian Family? I have heard of them, but what do they have anything to do with me? Don't tell me you believed that brat over there without any proof?"

"So you're not the leader of the Stone Bandits, and you have no affiliation with the Stone Bandits?" Yuan asked again.

"The answer is no to both of your questions. You should do some investigations before you accuse someone. I also expect some kind of compensation for the commotion you have caused my business today." The bulky man said.

Yuan suddenly smiled and retrieved an object that was emitting a golden glow.

"When someone lies before me, this Grail of Truth will light up, so what you just told me is a lie."

The bulky man took a few steps back after seeing this treasure. 'Where the fuck did he get such a powerful treasure?!' He cried inwardly.

Yuan turned to look at the young bandit and asked, "Have you been lying to me?"

"N-No!" The young bandit quickly said.

The Grail of Truth did not emit any light after hearing his words.

Yuan turned to look at the bulky man again and said, "This is all the proof that I need to deal with you."

"Xiao Yang! Is everything okay?! Why did you suddenly disappear like that?!" Tian Yanyu appeared at this moment with Xiao Hua following behind her.

"Hey, I just found our bandit boss." Yuan said.

"Really?!" Tian Yanyu frowned when she saw the bulky man's appearance.

"Y-You... I know him! I have seen him working as a guard for the Lin Family before!" She exclaimed after recognizing the bulky man's face.

Chapter 1071 Stone Bandits' Hideout(3)

Chapter 1071 Stone Bandits' Hideout(3)

"Hmph! So what if I have worked as a guard for the Lin Family? What are you trying to say?" The bulky man coldly snorted.

"I will get straight to the point then." Yuan said, "Did the Lin Family tell you to mess with the Tian Family?"

"..."

The bulky man kept his mouth shut this time, not daring to respond to Yuan's question, as this was the only flaw for Grail of Truth. However, one could argue if this was really a flaw, since if someone refuses to answer when they know what will happen if they do, it could only mean that they were going to lie.

"If you think silence will save you, I have bad news for you..." Yuan calmly said to the man.

"And what are you going to do to me? Kill me? You don't even have any concrete proof that I belong to this Stone Bandits or whatever." The bulky man sneered.

"Proof? In a world where the powerful is always right, proof is not necessary." Yuan spoke with a cold smile on his face, and his peak Spirit King aura that could suppress even a Spirit Emperor filled the hallways and nearby rooms, causing everyone to tremble before it.

Tian Yanyu stared at Yuan with wide eyes.

'This aura— He's a Spirit Emperor?! No! That's not possible! Spirit King is the peak in the Third Heaven! There's no way he's a Spirit Emperor!' She cried inwardly.

The bulky man subconsciously took a step back when he felt Yuan's aura, and he spoke in a nervous voice, "Y-You are powerful, I will give you that, but you won't be able to handle the Lin Family by yourself!"

Yuan chuckled, "Who said anything about dealing with the Lin Family by myself?"

"Anyways, are you going to tell me or not? I will not ask you again. My patience is running low."

The bulky man showed him a bold smile and said, "Go fuck—"

Whoosh!

Yuan suddenly retrieved his Empyrean Overlord and slashed it at the bulky man in a speed that was too quick to react.

The bulky man's head rolled on the floor the next moment before his body collapsed.

Tian Yanyu's jaw dropped a little after seeing this.

"Y-You actually killed him?" She almost couldn't believe that Yuan would kill the bulky man so quickly.

"It's pointless talking to him. There should be other high-ranking bandits that know about their deal with the Lin Family." Yuan said with a nonchalant look on his face, feeling not even the slightest guilt from killing a mere bandit that has caused the Tian Family so much trouble.

He turned to look at the horrified young bandit and said, "Go grab his head and bring me to the other bandits."

"Y-Yes!" Now realizing that Yuan was the real deal, the young bandit didn't dare to hesitate to listen to his commands.

He quickly went to pick up the bulky man's decapitated head and proceeded to bring Yuan around the building.

Whenever they encountered a bandit, Yuan would use the Grail of Truth to make sure that he wasn't troubling anyone innocent.

He would also ask the bandits questions, and when they refused to answer or try to run away, Tian Yanyu would act according to her own will and slay them. Of course, she would still kill them even if they answered their questions, as she could not forgive these bandits that have ruined their family business.

It was mayhem within the Passion Palace with blood being spilled all over the place.

Eventually, the guards arrived at the scene to stop the commotion.

"Halt!" A dozen peak Spirit Lords and a few Spirit Kings showed up before Yuan and Tian Yanyu.

"You are..." The guards immediately recognized Tian Yanyu because of her beauty, but they did not recognize Yuan.

"Lady Tian! What in heaven's name are you doing?! Why are you involved in this unscrupulous massacre?!" The guards asked her.

"Unscrupulous? How rude. I am merely cleaning up the bandits that have been messing with my Tian Family for years."

"Bandits?" The guards were taken aback by her words.

"The Stone Bandits. I'm sure you've heard of them. They're quite famous for human trafficking and robbery."

"Do you have any proof that the people you're killing are related to the Stone Bandits?" The leader of the guards asked after some pondering.

If Tian Yanyu was telling the truth— that she's cleaning up the bandits, the city would be awarding her for her efforts instead of being punished.

"Of course." Tian Yanyu nodded, and she pointed to the small group of bandits that they had captured and been dragging around the whole building.

"They all admitted to being part of the Stone Bandits, and they even confirmed that the Lin Family had paid them to mess with my Tian Family."

"What?!"

The guards were shocked after hearing this information.

The leader of the guards approached the group of bandits and asked them with a stern expression, "Is what she said true?"

"Y-Yes! We're all part of the Stone Bandits! Please! We'll tell you everything! Just save us from these monsters!" The bandits began crying.

They'd rather spend time behind bars than to deal with Yuan and Tian Yanyu.

The leader of the guards was speechless, and he said to Tian Yanyu, "We will deal with the rest from here. Please return to your home for now. We will visit you once we are done here."

She didn't say anything and turned to look at Yuan instead.

"We have already fulfilled our purpose here. Let's leave for now." Yuan said.

"Okay."

However, before they could leave, the leader of the guards asked Yuan, "Excuse me, who are you? I know of Lady Tian and the Tian Family, but I don't recognize you."

Yuan then answered, "My name is Xiao Yang. I am just a rogue cultivator who is currently in the process of repaying a debt my ancestor owed the Tian Family. If you need to speak with me, you can find me at the Tian Family."

"I-I understand..." The guard nodded in a dazed manner.

Yuan left the building and returned to the Tian Family with Tian Yanyu shortly after.

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Chapter 1072 Lin Family's Damage Control

Chapter 1072 Lin Family's Damage Control

Once Yuan and Tian Yanyu left the scene, the guards began their investigation on the Passion Palace and questioned all of the workers there.

Yuan also told the young bandit to assist the guards before leaving, which made it a lot easier for the guards to identify the bandits, speeding up their investigation tremendously.

News of what happened at the Passion Palace quickly began spreading throughout the city like wildfire, and rumors of the Lin Family paying the Stone Bandits to mess with the Tian Family was amongst the news, which shocked the city.

This caused quite the backlash for the Lin Family. Even though there wasn't any direct backlash, their family name was being dragged through the mud by being associated with the bandits, which was more than enough to make them lose face, and losing face is the worst thing that could happen to these influential families that only care about such things.

The Lin Family quickly went into damage control and tried their best to convince the people that the Stone Bandits were lying to mess with their reputation and that they weren't trustworthy because, well, they were bandits, even going as far as spending money to spread it.

Although this did alleviate some of their troubles, not everyone believed it.

"Fuck! Fuck! Fuck! That fucking bitch Tian Yanyu! How dare she mess with us like this!" A handsome young man within the Lin Family kicked the table in front of him when he heard the news of Tian Yanyu dealing with the Stone Bandits, sending it along with everything on it flying across the room.

Things have gone so smoothly for him for the past few years that this sudden retaliation from the Tian Family had taken him by complete surprise.

"I swear I am going to make her regret defying me— the Lin Family!"

This handsome young man was Lin Minghai, who has been courting Tian Yanyu for the last few years without any success.

"Young Master Lin, please calm down. If we act against the Tian Family now, it would only solidify the rumors that we're working with the Stone Bandits." The servant of the Lin Family said to him.

"Are you telling me to just sit here and let that bitch spit on my face?! I refuse!" Lin Minghai roared.

"I did not say that, Young Master. I'm just saying that there are better ways to go around this. For example, you can use this chance to visit the Tian Family and demand compensation for ruining the Lin Family's reputation."

"Hahaha! This is a great idea, Steward Jin!" Lin Minghai laughed out loud.

"Prepare the guards! We're going to visit the Tian Family right now!"

Meanwhile, at the Tian Family, Tian Xianzu was in disbelief after hearing about the situation from his daughter.

"We not only dealt with the hooligans, but we even cleaned out the infamous Stone Bandits in half a day! Yuan is the real deal! He will definitely be able to help us get the Lin Family off our backs!" Tian Yanyu spoke with intense excitement, as this incident had relieved a lot of her built up stress.

'Is this what victory feels like?' She tightly gripped her hands into fists.

"This is just the beginning." Yuan suddenly said. "Now that we've taken care of the bandits, one of three things will happen."

"One, the Lin Family will pretend it never happened and not bother us for a bit. Two, they could send more people to mess with us, or they will come to us directly."

"Personally, I would prefer it if they directly came to us, as that would make things easier."

Tian Xianzu sighed, "Regardless of their actions, they will not forget what happened today and will definitely try to get revenge. In their eyes, even though we only dealt with the hooligans, we had indirectly defied them, which isn't any different from directly defying them."

He turned to look at Yuan and continued, "I really hope you know what you're doing, because if things go south, your little antics will mark the end of our Tian Family."

Yuan smiled, "Don't worry, I will keep the Tian Family safe even if I have to wipe out the Seven Legacy Families in order to do so."

"You... I know you're powerful, but how can you say such a thing so casually? The more you go against the Seven Legacy Families the more they will retaliate. If they cannot handle you in this world, they will send people from the upper heavens down here. This is the main reason why nobody dares to mess with them, unless you also have a family in the upper heaven, such as the Four Ancient Families." Tian Yanyu said.

"Because this is not my first time confronting one of the Seven Legacy Families." Yuan calmly responded, leaving them speechless.

'Dear heaven, what have we gotten ourselves into...? Just who is this young man?' Tian Xianzu cried inwardly.

Meanwhile, inside a sect somewhere in the Third Heaven.

"E-Elder Suyin! This is an emergency!" A middle-aged man hastily approached a beautiful middle-aged woman in a square with a nervous look on his face.

The middle-aged woman stopped lecturing her disciples and turned to look at the middle-aged man, "Elder Long? What happened?"

"This is about your family! I have just received news that your daughter, Tian Yanyu, had caused a commotion, which resulted in the Lin Family losing a tremendous amount of face!"

"What?! What did my silly daughter do?!" Elder Suyin, also known as Tian Suyin and who was Tian Yanyu's mother, exclaimed.

Elder Long proceeded to explain the whole incident between Tian Yanyu and the Stone Bandits to Tian Suyin.

"That foolish girl! I warned her countless times to not mess with the Lin Family and just ignore them!" Tian Suyin gritted her teeth in frustration after learning about the situation.

"I'm going to return home for a bit. Can you let the Sect Leader know about my situation?" She then said.

"Of course." Elder Long nodded.

After dismissing her disciples, Tian Suyin left her sect and rushed back to the Silver Heaven City.

Chapter 1073 Lin Family's Visit

Chapter 1073 Lin Family's Visit

DONG! DONG! DONG!

"Tian Family! Get your ass out here! The Lin Family is here to demand for answers!"

Yuan and the others heard the front door being banged on and a loud voice resound the following moment.

"Looks like the Lin Family decided to show up personally, and they even moved faster than I anticipated." Yuan smiled.

"What should we do?" Tian Yanyu asked.

"Since you caused this mess, you're going to deal with it." Tian Xianzu said in a cold voice, pushing all responsibility to them even though he's the family head.

Tian Yanyu turned to look at Yuan, who spoke in a calm voice, "Let's meet them and see what they have to say. If they do anything inappropriate, I will deal with them accordingly."

"Alright." Tian Yanyu nodded.

The two of them went to greet the visitors shortly after, and then they brought the Lin Family to one of the guest rooms.

"Tian Yanyu! You bitch! Do you have any idea how much trouble you have caused for my family with your little act at the Passion Palace today?! How

dare you spread such nasty rumors! You will compensate us for the damage!" Lin Minghai began shouting even before they sat down.

Tian Yanyu remained calm and spoke in a sneering voice, "The Stone Bandits claimed that your Lin Family hired them to mess with my family. I had nothing to do with it. If you want to blame someone, blame the bandits — or even better, blame yourselves for messing with my family!"

Lin Minghai slammed on the table and roared, "Our Lin Family had nothing to do with those filthy bandits! How dare you slander us?!"

"Slander? Those hooligans started messing with my family's business the day I rejected your advances, and don't even think about giving the excuse that it's all just a coincidence. Even an idiot wouldn't believe such an excuse!" Tian Yanyu bit back at them.

"Watch your attitude, Lady Tian! You are speaking to the Young Master of the Lin Family!" Steward Jin suddenly spoke in a cold tone.

"If you weren't the Young Master's darling, I would have already cut out your tongue!"

"Watch your mouth. I am not his darling." Tian Yanyu narrowed her eyes at Steward Jin, her gaze oozing with killing intent.

"I may be a servant, but do you dare to kill a member of the Lin Family in your estate? Can you handle the consequences?" Steward Jin snorted arrogantly.

Even though he called himself a servant, his status within the Lin Family wasn't low, and he has been a trusted member for many decades now, his loyalty for the Lin Family unquestionable.

"Why don't we all calm down so that we can have a proper conversation?" Yuan finally spoke his first sentence since the Lin Family's visit.

The frown on Lin Minghai's face immediately burrowed even further, and he turned to look at Yuan, "And who the fuck are you?"

Yuan smiled and introduced himself in a respectful voice, "My name is Xiao Yang, and I am currently assisting the Tian Family. My ancestors owed their ancestors a debt, and I am here to return that debt. I was told that their family business was being harassed by hooligans, so I decided to do something about it, unaware that they were connected to the reputable Lin Family. If you want to blame someone for the recent commotion, you may place the blame on me."

"You're also slandering my Lin Family?!" Lin Minghai fumed with anger after hearing Yuan's words that subtly accused the Lin Family of working with the Stone Bandits.

"What? I am simply stating what the bandits told us and the guards that took them away. If you claim that the Lin Family doesn't have anything to do with those bandits, I naturally want to believe the reputable Lin Family over the bandits. However, your inappropriate behavior isn't helping me."

Lin Minghai gritted his teeth in frustration, but he couldn't argue back, as that would only make him and his family look worse.

"Xiao Yang, right? I will remember your name. Now I have a question for you. What is your relationship with her?" Lin Minghai pointed at Tian Yanyu while he spoke.

"My relationship with Miss Yanyu? We're just—"

It was at this moment that Tian Yanyu suddenly interrupted, "We're just ordinary lovers. What about it?"

Yuan's eyes widened after hearing Tian Yanyu's words.

Lin Minghai had a look of disbelief on his face, looking as though he'd just witnessed a ghost for the first time.

"Y-Y-You're lying!" Lin Minghai didn't dare to believe it.

"Oh? You don't believe me? Then let me prove it to you." Tian Yanyu suddenly turned to look at Yuan's handsome face and moved her head

towards his, giving him a passionate kiss on the lips the following moment.

Lin Minghai could feel his heart bursting into a million pieces when he witnessed this, and the shock he'd received was so big that his eyes rolled backwards until it was almost completely white.

"Y-Young Master! Get a hold of yourself!" Steward Jin cried out loud as he went to catch Lin Minghai's falling body.

After removing her lips from Yuan's, Tian Yanyu spoke with a slightly rosy face, "Why are you so surprised? We're lovers, so it's only natural for us to do things like this. In fact, we have done even more intensive stuff before."

Lin Minghai felt his soul leaving his body after hearing what Tian Yanyu had just said.

"Y-You will regret this, you damn whore! We're going back!" Steward Jin decided to return to the Lin Family for now because their Young Master had become incapacitated from mental damage, and he was worried that if they stayed any longer, Lin Minghai might die of heartbreak.

After carrying their Young Master away, the Lin Family rushed back to their own home.

Yuan turned to look at Tian Yanyu with a bittersweet smile, but he didn't say anything, as he wanted her to tell him what that was about just now.

Chapter 1074 Caused by Heartbreak

Chapter 1074 Caused by Heartbreak

"What's wrong? Did you not like that kiss? Or was that your first kiss?" Tian Yanyu tried her best to remain calm as she responded to Yuan's puzzled face.

"Most people would kill to receive a kiss from a beauty like me." She added.

Yuan shook his head, "This has nothing to do with that. Are you sure that was the right choice? Who knows how Lin Minghai will act now. Perhaps you'd even made things worse by kissing me. After all, that was the only reason the Lin Family hasn't taken over the Tian Family."

"It'll be fine. If anything happens, you'll protect us, right? That's what you said. Furthermore, I have been wanting to get back at Lin Minghai for a while now. I just didn't know how, until a few moments ago."

Yuan rubbed his eyes and sighed.

"So, what are we going to do now? What's the next step?" Tian Yanyu asked a moment later.

"There is no next step. We will now wait to see the Lin Family's response. With that being said, we're not going to wait forever for a response. I will give them a week at most."

"Alright..."

"Anyways, do you have any unused rooms? And do you mind if I stay here for a while? In order to keep you all safe, it would be for the best if I stayed close. This way, if anything happens, I will be able to respond to it faster." Yuan asked a moment later.

"Sure. We have plenty of unused guest rooms. You can use them as you please." Tian Yanyu nodded.

"Follow me. I will show you the way."

"Thank you."

After showing Yuan to his room, Tian Yanyu left him alone to cultivate before returning to her room.

Once she closed the doors to her room, Tian Yanyu jumped onto the bed and began rolling around the bed.

'Ahhhhh!' She screamed internally.

"I can't believe that I had actually kissed him! That was even my first kiss!" She exclaimed in a low voice.

While Tian Yanyu pondered about her actions inside her room, Yuan cultivated in peace in his room— at least he tried to.

"Young Master! How could you let that woman kiss you like that?! You should've dodged it!" Feng Yuxiang was making a fuss about the kiss.

"Calm down, it's just a kiss."

"Just a kiss?! Kissing is more than that! You just shared saliva! That's not something you do to someone whom you've just met!" She exclaimed.

"What's done is already done. There's no point getting excited over it now." He sighed.

"Fine, then let's talk about something else." Feng Yuxiang said.

And she continued, "You asked her if it was a good idea to kiss you in front of Lin Minghai. I will now ask you if it's really a good idea to meddle with the Tian Family's affairs. In case you forgot, we're currently being hunted by the Seven Legacy Families, and the Lin Family is part of them. Even if your intentions are to help them, if the Lin Family finds out your true identity, the Tian Family will be dragged into our mess, and they will be executed. I guarantee it."

"Senior Feng is right, Yuan. I don't see any benefits from this while there are tons of risks. It just doesn't make sense to me." Lan Yingying also gave her opinion on the matter, something she doesn't do often.

Yuan showed a slight smile and said, "I am well aware of how foolish my actions are right now, but it's more complicated than you think. You know, after Tian Chenyu left his family to deal with the demons, he never once got the chance to return home to see his family before they passed away."

"The parents that had raised him with love and care— the ones who supported him while he was at his lowest— Tian Chenyu greatly regretted not being able to help his family, as his parents had died before his mentality could stabilize."

"Now that I have Tian Chenyu's memories, there is this strong and nearly uncontrollable urge to help the Tian Family, almost as though his soul desperately wants to amend his mistakes. I could ignore this feeling and pretend I don't even know the Tian Family, but I have a feeling that this will hinder my cultivation in the future, almost like Heart Demon."

"I see... I understand your motivation a little better now, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang said a moment later.

"Me too." Lan Yingying said.

"I also understand your worries, and I thank you for your consideration, but there's no need to worry, as I don't plan on exposing myself, and I have the perfect plan to deal with the Lin Family without spewing any blood— if they don't suddenly decide to raid the Tian Family in the middle of the night." Yuan said.

And he continued, "The moment they do anything drastic, I will get rid of them, no matter if they are the Seven Legacy Families or some other powerhouse."

Meanwhile, back at the Lin Family, Steward Jin called for their best doctor after putting Lin Minghai in his luxurious bed.

"What happened to the Young Master?!" The doctor was shocked when he saw Lin Minghai's poor condition.

'His skin is completely pale, almost as if all of his blood had been drained, not to mention the horrified expression on his face... Did he see a ghost or something? No, even a ghost wouldn't be enough to cause such a reaction. Just what in heaven's name happened?' The doctor quickly assessed Lin Minghai's condition.

"You see... What had happened was..."

Steward Jin explained the situation to the doctor, which made him even more baffled.

"The reason for the Young Master's condition is heartbreak?!" He couldn't help but cry out loud, as he has never seen a case of heartbreak this drastic before.

'Isn't this a little bit too much of an overreaction? It's not like he had been forced to watch his lover being screwed by someone else.' The doctor sighed inwardly.

Chapter 1075 Silent Rippers

Chapter 1075 Silent Rippers

Lin Minghua eventually woke up after a whole day of rest, and when he woke up, he did so in a manner that was as though he'd just woken up from a nightmare.

"Aaaah!" He shouted the moment he woke up.

"Young Master! It's okay! Young Master!" Steward Jin quickly rushed to his side to calm him down.

"Steward Jin? What is going on? Where am I?" Lin Minghai looked around with a puzzled look on his face. He was so confused that he couldn't even recognize his own bedroom.

"We're currently inside your bedroom right now." Steward Jin said.

"M-My room? I see! So that was just a dream—a bad nightmare!" Lin Minghai released a sigh of relief, his whole body soaked in sweat.

It was obvious that Lin Minghai thought that his visit to the Tian Family and what he experienced there was just a dream.

Unfortunately for him, Steward Jin would turn that dream into reality with a single sentence.

"I'm sorry, Young Master, but that wasn't a dream. We brought you back here from the Tian Family after you fell unconscious."

Lin Minghai proceeded to sit on his bed with a blank expression on his face after hearing Steward Jin's words, feeling as though he'd accidentally

inhaled a live fly.

His face began to flush with redness shortly after.

Once he reached the boiling point, he roared at the top of his lungs, "FUCK THAT BITCH TIAN YANYU!"

"I WANT THEM DEAD! I WANT THEM ALL DEAD!"

Steward Jin expected this kind of reaction from him, which wasn't surprising in the least. However, he couldn't allow it to happen.

"Young Master, with the way things are going, if we attack them now, it will look bad on the Lin Family."

"I don't fucking care! If you won't do it, I will do it myself! Nobody can stop me from killing that whore— not even my parents!" Lin Minghai continued shouting.

Steward Jin shook his head inwardly.

He then sighed, "I understand, Young Master. I will assemble a team of assassins to deal with Xiao Yang to send a message for now. As for Tian Yanyu and her family, we can deal with them a little later. How does that sound, Young Master?"

Lin Minghai pondered for a moment before nodding with a cold smile on his face, "Kill her lover and torment her mentally before killing her, huh? That's a great idea! And since this Xiao Yang isn't part of the Tian Family, we won't receive any backlash for killing him! We can even call him a fugitive who had wronged our family!"

"That's right, Young Master."

"Go on! Get with it! I want this bastard gone by tomorrow!"

"Of course." Steward Jin disappeared from the room shortly after while Lin Minghai continued to rest.

After leaving Lin Minghai's side, Steward Jin went to write a note before sending it to the most notorious assassins within the Third Heaven—the Silent Rippers.

The Silent Rippers are a small group of professional assassins that would kill pretty much anybody as long as they are paid enough for the job, and they have even dared to kill people from the Seven Legacy Families before.

The Silent Rippers also have no hideout, and they always wander the Third Heaven, never staying in one place for longer than a few days, hence why they are so hard to catch and deal with.

However, they do have several methods of contact, and one of them is leaving behind a note as well as a full deposit in a specific location. These locations exist all over the Nine Heavens, and they are usually checked once every week.

Fortunately for Steward Lin, his note was received by a member of the Silent Ripper merely hours after he sent it out.

[I want someone named Xiao Yang to be taken care of as soon as possible. He is currently residing in the Tian Family's residence within Silver Heaven City. It is very important that you not kill anyone from the Tian Family—just Xiao Yang. He is a young man around 20 years old, around 6ft tall, handsome face, long black hair tied into a ponytail, brown eyes, and his cultivation seems to be around Spirit King. The pay will be 20,000,000 spirit stones. If you need more information or wish to contact me, you can contact one of my associates in the Yellow River Pavilion in Silver Heaven City. He is someone by the name of Ming Lao.]

Attached to this note was a storage bag with 20,000,000 spirit stones.

Normally, one wouldn't dare to risk 20,000,000 spirit stones before the job is completed, but the Silent Rippers are very proud of their reputation and have never stolen from their client before, hence why Steward Jin didn't hesitate to pay them 20 million spirit stones in advance.

"Hahaha! 20 million spirit stones to kill a mere child?! This is the easiest money in a long time!" The assassin laughed out loud when he saw the new request.

He then contacted his fellow assassins and notified them of the new mission.

"Spirit King at the Silver Heaven City, huh? Brother Mao should be the nearest to that city right now."

"Yes, I can get there in about three hours from my current location." This assassin surnamed Mao said.

"I'm about 8 hours away. Do you want to wait for me?" Another asked.

"No, I will be fine by myself. It's just a 20-year-old child who just became a Spirit King. I am already more than enough for this mission," said Assassin Mao.

"Alright, we'll leave this mission in your hands, Brother Mao."

"We will await for the good news, Brother Mao."

"Good luck."

"I will finish it by tonight."

After closing the connection to his communication jade slip, Assassin Mao immediately made his way to Silver Heaven City, unaware of the grim reaper that was waiting for him there.

Chapter 1076 Midnight Assassination Attempt

Chapter 1076 Midnight Assassination Attempt

Later that night, after eating dinner with the Tian Family, Yuan returned to his room.

Inside his room, Yuan practiced the Soul Nourishment Array that Huang Chen had taught him.

Golden array symbols filled the room, and Yuan could feel his soul strength strengthening very slightly.

A few hours into the night, when it was slightly past midnight, Feng Yuxiang suddenly said, "Young Master, there's an expert nearby, and he's spying on us."

Still focused on his array symbols, Yuan casually said, "I am aware. Let's just wait and see what he's planning on doing first. Don't come out. I don't want to alert him."

"I understand."

Unbeknownst to the Assassin Mao, his presence had already been noticed by his target.

'A mere child. I will finish this in a minute and leave.' Assassin Mao suddenly consumed a pill, which altered his appearance to look exactly like Tian Yanyu.

After making sure that there was nobody near Yuan's room, he approached the door and knocked on it.

Yuan stopped whatever he was doing and went to open the door to find Tian Yanyu standing there.

And without saying a word, Assassin Mao entered the room with a seductive smile on his face.

"Miss Yanyu? What's wrong? Are you still worried about the Lin Family? I'm telling you, it'll be fine." Yuan said to her with a gentle smile on his face.

Assassin Mao laughed inwardly, feeling quite gleeful about how well his plan was working.

He then placed his hands on Yuan's shoulders before guiding him to the bed.

"Oh? What are you doing?" Yuan asked her as he laid on the bed, looking a little nervous.

Assassin Mao, still with Tian Yanyu's appearance, placed a finger on his own lips and made a quite shushing sound.

"Shhh..."

"Ah... I see..." Yuan's nervous smile became filled with excitement, and he closed his eyes.

"Go ahead. Do whatever you want."

It was at this moment Assassin Mao retrieved a dagger from his spatial ring and stabbed it towards Yuan's chest where his heart was located.

"DIE!"

Assassin Mao shouted when the tip of the blade reached Yuan's chest.

However, almost as though he'd struck steel, the blade halted right on top of Yuan's clothes.

Yuan slowly opened his eyes and spoke in a calm voice, his gaze completely tranquil, "This wasn't what I had in mind, Miss Yanyu."

'Shit!'

Assassin Mao had no idea what had just happened and couldn't comprehend why he couldn't penetrate Yuan's skin with his Heaven-grade spiritual treasure.

However, it was clear to him that his target was still alive.

Assassin Mao suddenly released his cultivation base, filling the room with the aura of a 5th level Spirit King.

He then lifted his dagger into the air and plunged it down for a second time.

However, just like the last time, his dagger was stopped by Yuan's skin.

"I don't think this is how you captivate a man's heart, Miss Yanyu." Yuan uttered this remark in a sarcastic tone.

"H-How...?!" Assassin Mao was in disbelief, and he tried pushing his dagger with all of his might, but it was pointless.

It was at this moment Assassin Mao and Yuan could hear the sound of footsteps rushing towards their location.

"Yuan! Is everything okay?! What was that spiritual energy just now?!" Tian Yanyu's panicked voice resounded.

"Fuck!" Realizing that his mission had failed, Assassin Mao immediately turned towards the door and prepared to escape.

However, right as he reached the door, a hand suddenly grabbed his neck from behind, yanking him back into the room.

"Ugh!" Assassin Mao tried to break the hold on his neck, but he was unsuccessful.

Tian Yanyu and her caretaker showed up a moment later to see Yuan choking someone who looked exactly like Tian Yanyu.

"W-What in heaven's name is going on here?!" Tian Yanyu exclaimed when she saw this puzzling scene.

"Hey, Miss Yanyu. This rat disguised as you just tried to assassinate me." Yuan calmly explained to her.

"What?!"

"Let me go, you bastard!" Assassin Mao spoke in his original voice, startling Tian Yanyu.

And he continued, "Do you know who I am?! If you don't let me go, my fellow brothers and sisters from the Silent Rippers will hunt you down!"

"Silent Rippers?!" Tian Yanyu was terrified upon hearing this name.

However, Yuan didn't recognize them and asked, "Silent Rippers? Never heard of you guys. Are you mercenaries or bandits?"

"Y-Yuan! They're neither of those! They're a notorious group of assassins that have terrorized the Third Heaven for hundreds of years!" Tian Yanyu quickly said.

"Oh? Assassins, huh? This meant someone had put a hit on me. Who was it? The Lin Family?"

"As if I'd tell you anything! Hurry up and unhand me! If my companions don't hear from me by tomorrow, they will all come rushing here!" Assassin Mao said.

"I'm already being hunted, so it wouldn't make a difference if I kill you or not, since I will be hunted anyways." Yuan smiled.

"W-Wait! We can work something out!" Assassin Mao quickly said.

"You have a minute to change my mind."

"We will stop the assassination and go after those that tried you kill you! How does that sound?" Assassin Mao said.

"Don't listen to him, Yuan!" Tian Yanyu suddenly said.

"The Silent Rippers will always finish their job! And since the Lin Family is involved, they won't stop hunting you unless the Lin Family cancels the mission!"

Yuan smiled and said, "I never intended to listen to him. I just wanted to see what kind of excuse he'll give."

"W-W-Wait! I swear! I am not lying! If you kill me, my companions will definitely kill you!"

"Then I shouldn't waste anymore time and start preparing to greet them." Yuan said, and without any hesitation, crushed the assassin's neck, killing him in an instant.

When Assassin Mao's body limped, Yuan tossed his body out into the courtyard and dusted his hands.

"..."

Tian Yanyu stared at Assassin Mao's dead body with a speechless look on her face.

'He killed one of the Silent Ripper's assassins just like that? Just how powerful is he?' She wondered inwardly.

Chapter 1077 Dealing with the Silent Rippers

Chapter 1077 Dealing with the Silent Rippers

"Oh, I should've questioned him before killing him. Whatever. More of them will come sooner or later anyway." Yuan realized this after killing Assassin Mao.

"Y-Young Lady! We must evacuate from this place as soon as possible before the Silent Rippers raid this place!" The old lady exclaimed in a panicked manner after she snapped out of her daze.

"Evacuate? Leave where? Where can we go? If we're being targeted by the Silent Rippers, there is nowhere in this world we can hide!" Tian Yanyu said with a frown.

"But we have to try! Not only did we offend the Lin Family, but we're now targeted by the Silent Rippers! This is literally the worst-case scenario!"

Tian Xianzu showed up shortly after with a profound frown on his face.

"What is this commotion?" He asked them, unaware of the situation.

Tian Yanyu pointed at the corpse in their courtyard and explained the situation to him.

"What?! The Silent Rippers?! Those Lin Family bastards actually went as far as to hire the most notorious assassins in the whole Third Heaven?! Are they insane?!"

"Master, I think we should evacuate this place as soon as possible." The old lady said.

Tian Xianzhu sighed, "Even if we run away and hide in the sewers, the Silent Rippers will eventually find us."

"Calm down, all of you." Yuan finally spoke, and he said, "The best course of action right now is to stay here, where I can protect all of you."

"How delusional!" The old lady suddenly shouted.

"You don't even know anything about the Silent Rippers nor how terrifying they can be! The Silent Rippers may only be a small group of assassins, but they are the best of the best within the Third Heaven, and they even have several peak Spirit Kings amongst their ranks! Do you really think you can protect us from the Silent Ripper by yourself?! There should be a limit to your arrogance!"

"O-Old Zou, please calm down..." Tian Yanyu said to her, who was breathing heavily and filled with anger.

"She is right, Yuan. Even the Seven Legacy Families cannot handle the Silent Rippers alone, much less a single person." Tian Xianzhu shook his head in a dispirited manner, seemingly already given up.

Yuan smiled and said, "Who said that I will be alone?"

"You guys, come out."

The very next moment, three figures appeared beside Yuan, startling the Tian Family.

"Let me introduce you guys to my companions. This is Xiao Hua, whom you've already met. Don't be fooled by her young appearance because she's actually a Spirit King." Yuan pointed at Xiao Hua.

"This is Feng Yuxiang, who is also a peak Spirit King."

"This is Lan Yingying. She may only be a Spirit Lord, but she can handle Spirit Kings by herself."

"E-Even if you have three more people, that won't change anything..." Old Zou said.

Yuan chuckled, "Don't underestimate my friends, and don't compare them to your average cultivators, because they are not human."

"W-What do you mean by that?" Tian Xianzu swallowed nervously.

"They are Divine Beasts. Feng Yuxiang is a phoenix, and Lan Yingying is a divine serpent."

"They're what?!" The Tian Family couldn't believe their ears.

Divine Beasts are akin to divine entities in their eyes, and there were two of them before them right this moment.

"Anyways, no matter if they are the Silent Rippers or the Lin Family. With them here, nobody will be able to harm you guys." Yuan reassured them.

The Tian Family eventually calmed down and decided to trust him.

Meanwhile, the Silent Rippers had another meeting with each other through communication jade slips.

"Brother Mao's life slip just broke. He's dead." A solemn voice spoke.

"How is this possible?! Brother Mao is a 5th level Spirit King! His target is only around 20 years old, right?! There's no way Brother Mao could lose to someone like that!"

"Perhaps the target has a powerful bodyguard beside him." Another said.

"That is likely what happened. Let's gather and avenge Brother Mao."

"Yes!"

A few days later.

"Steward Lin! What the fuck is going on?! Why is that bastard Xiao Yang still alive?! He was even spotted eating merrily at the Heavenly Restaurant today!" Lin Minghai demanded an answer after hearing about this news.

"Please be patient, Young Master. I have already hired the Silent Rippers to take care of Xiao Yang. It will only be a matter of time." Steward Jin said.

However, his communication jade slip trembled a moment later, and this jade slip was used to communicate with Ming Lao, who was supposed to contact him if the Silent Rippers contacted.

"What happened?" Steward Jin asked.

"T-The Silent Ripper is asking for your presence! Please come to the Yellow River Pavilion as soon as possible, Senior Jin!"

"I understand. Tell them that I will be there within 15 minutes."

Steward Jin then said to Lin Minghai, "The Silent Ripper has made contact with us. I will go speak with them now."

Sometime later, he arrived at the Yellow River Restaurant.

After finding his friend Ming Lao, he also noticed a skinny man sitting at the same table.

This skinny man exuded no presence and appeared to be a mortal, but Steward Jin immediately knew the man's identity.

"Greetings, Senior." Steward Jin bowed to this skinny man.

"Take a seat." The skinny man spoke in an authoritative voice.

Once he was seated, Steward Jin asked, "How may I address this senior?"

"You can just call me Kong."

"I understand, Senior Kong."

Assassin Kong then spoke, "Now then, I called you here to verify some things."

"This Xiao Yang... Is he being guarded by an expert?"

"As far as I am aware, he's not." Steward Jin shook his head.

"He's not?"

"He's not. According to my investigation, there is only a little girl by his side. Unless that little girl is actually an expert in disguise, I don't think he has any other bodyguard."

"A little girl, huh." Assassin Kong began pondering in silence.

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Chapter 1078 Dealing with the Silent Rippers(2)

Chapter 1078 Dealing with the Silent Rippers(2)

After pondering for some time, Assassin Kong spoke in a grim voice, "One of our brothers has died already, and he was a 5th level Spirit King."

"What?!" Steward Jin exclaimed out loud after hearing this shocking information.

"Quiet!" Assassin Kong glared at him.

He then continued, "This Xiao Yang is clearly much more difficult to kill than you thought, so we are asking for an increased payment."

"How much more are you asking?" Steward Jin asked with a solemn expression.

"10 million." Assassin Kong blurted this number out without any hesitation.

"T-Ten million..." Steward Jin swallowed nervously.

He was already being extremely generous with 20 million spirit stones to get rid of a child, so adding another 10 million definitely made him hesitate.

'Since that Xiao Yang has already killed one of their members, they won't stop hunting him even if I refuse, but that is a very risky decision, especially since I gave them this mission.' Steward Jin sighed inwardly.

He was confident that the Silent Rippers would go after Yuan even if he doesn't pay the extra ten million, but he could be killed by them if he took

advantage of this knowledge.

In the end, he had to bite the bullet and agree to pay an extra 10 million spirit stones.

"You can send the money to the same location. We will pick it up in two days." Assassin Kong said.

"I understand."

Assassin Kong left the restaurant shortly after.

"Thank you, Ming Lao." Steward Jin handed a hundred spirit stones to Ming Lao for his work before leaving the restaurant as well.

Meanwhile, at the Tian Family, Tian Yanyu sat in her room with Feng Yuxiang sitting not far away.

"It's been several days since then. When will the Silent Rippers come? This wait is making me anxious. I cannot concentrate on my cultivation under this stress!" Tian Yanyu sighed out loud.

"You've been complaining about this since the first day. When will you stop?" Feng Yuxiang said.

And she continued in a sighing voice, "Why did I get stuck with you?"

"What's wrong with me? Besides my 'complaining'." Tian Yanyu asked.

"Hmph." Feng Yuxiang coldly snorted, and she said, "Don't think I have forgotten already. You kissed my Young Master without his permission. If he wasn't helping you, I would've burned you to death on the spot at that time."

"Seriously...? It's just a kiss..." Tian Yanyu said.

"Just a kiss?! Do you know who the Young Master is?!" Feng Yuxiang exclaimed.

"No, I don't. If you tell me, I will." Tian Yanyu smiled.

"..."

Feng Yuxiang became speechless, mostly because she also didn't know Yuan's true background, and his prior lives didn't count.

"The Young Master is someone—"

Just as she opened her mouth, Feng Yuxiang suddenly halted her words, and her face turned serious.

"They are here," she said in a solemn voice.

"T-The Silent Rippers?!" Tian Yanyu immediately jumped to her feet and retrieved her weapon.

Feng Yuxiang nodded, "Yes, but there's something odd about them. They're only focusing on the Young Master for some reason."

"On Yuan? Will he be fine alone?" Tian Yanyu asked, as Xiao Hua was with Tian Xianzu and Lan Yingying was with the servants and Old Zou.

"Yes. No matter how many people come for him, he will be fine." Feng Yuxiang said with a confident look on her face.

Meanwhile, a few rooms away from Tian Yanyu's room, when he noticed the presence surrounding the Tian Family's residence, Yuan calmly opened the door and went outside to the courtyard.

'Seventeen people, all Spirit Kings, huh.' Yuan assessed all of the assassins with his divine sense that covered the entire house and more.

When the assassins saw his action, they quickly realized that their presence was exposed.

Since their target is already aware of their presence, they decided to show themselves, surrounding Yuan in the courtyard a moment later.

"Are you the bastard who killed Brother Mao?" One of them asked him in a cold voice.

"Is that the name of the assassin from a few days ago?" Yuan asked them. "If so, yes, I killed him. Don't worry, I made sure it was a quick and painless death."

The assassins' trembled in anger when they heard his words, and they all released their aura, which bore down on Yuan like a mountain.

However, Yuan remained standing there with a calm look on his face, almost as if he couldn't even feel the pressure.

This surprised the assassins. There were 4 peak Spirit Kings amongst them, yet they cannot make a single Spirit King bow down with their pressure? Something was wrong here.

"So you're saying that you don't have any bodyguards? That you killed Brother Mao by yourself?"

Yuan showed them a provocative smile and said, "A weakling like him— it didn't take much effort."

"YOU BASTARD!"

One of the seventeen assassins couldn't hold his rage any longer and lunged at Yuan.

Without even turning to look at the attacker, Yuan calmly dodged his strike before catching him by the neck.

The others immediately went into an offensive position when they saw this.

"If you're smart, you will let him go," said a skinny man.

"If I do, will you spare my life?" Yuan asked him.

"..."

Assassin Kong didn't respond—he couldn't.

"I figured." Yuan mumbled, and without hesitation, he crushed the neck of the assassin in his grasp.

"KILL HIM!" Assassin Kong roared with bloodshot eyes.

The others sprang into action, and they attacked Yuan from multiple directions.

Daggers, throwing knives, hidden weapons—the assassins attacked Yuan with pretty much every weapon used by assassins.

However, almost as though his body was made of the world's strongest steel, the weapons bounced off his body.

"What the fuck?!" The assassins were surprised when they saw this.

"He must have some kind of spiritual treasure protecting him!" They quickly came to this conclusion.

"Keep attacking! It can only endure so much!" Assassin Kong said.

Thus, the assassins continued to attack Yuan while he casually stood there without a care in the world.

"What in heaven's name..." Tian Yanyu was left speechless when she witnessed this scene with her divine sense.

"I told you that he would be fine." Feng Yuxiang said with a smile.

Chapter 1079 Dealing with the Silent Rippers(3)

Chapter 1079 Dealing with the Silent Rippers(3)

After trying for many minutes and failing to break through Yuan's invisible armor, the Silent Rippers stopped their attacks momentarily.

"Fucking hell, what kind of trick are you using?!"

"Stop standing there and fight us like a real cultivator!"

The assassins tried to get him to remove his invisible armor.

Yuan merely laughed at them, "I'm not using any tricks. You're all just too weak to damage my Perfect Physique."

"What? Perfect Physique? That's just a legend! There's no way you actually have the Perfect Physique!" Assassin Kong exclaimed.

"I don't care if you believe me or not." Yuan shrugged.

"Anyways, tell me, what is your mission? Is it just to assassinate me, or are you going to harm the Tian Family as well? If you tell me, I will remove my armor."

"So you are wearing a spiritual treasure!"

Yuan raised an eyebrow, "I never said that I didn't. I merely said that I wasn't using any tricks. Can wearing armor be considered a trick? I don't think so."

After a moment of silence, Assassin Kong spoke, "Our mission is only to kill you, Xiao Yang. We were instructed to not touch the Tian Family. Are you happy now?"

"Yes, I am quite happy. Here, I will keep my words and take my armor off for you." Yuan proceeded to take off his Invisible Dragon Cloak.

"NOW!" Assassin Kong suddenly roared.

All sixteen assassins sprung into action instantly, attacking Yuan with everything they got.

A slight grin appeared on Yuan's face right before an immense pressure suddenly covered the entire courtyard.

This pressure forced all of the assassins to their knees with the peak Spirit Kings barely resisting it.

"W-What is this?!" The assassins began panicking.

"Heavenly Domain." Yuan calmly responded.

"Are you guys really the most notorious assassins in the Third Heaven? You're not much better than the Stone Bandits." He proceeded to mock them.

"Screw... You!" Assassin Kong and the other peak Spirit Kings managed to stand up despite the Heavenly Domain pressuring them.

However, their movements were still severely restricted.

It was at this moment that Yuan retrieved the Empyrean Overlord, and he proceeded to kill the assassins one by one, starting from those that couldn't resist the Heavenly Domain.

"STOP!"

"AAAAAAH!"

"I WILL KILL YOU!"

The assassins roared like beasts when their companions were killed before their eyes and they couldn't do anything to stop it.

Within moments, Yuan had cut their number all the way down to just one.

"Is this all of you? Or will there be more coming later?" Yuan asked Assassin Kong.

Assassin Kong just kneeled there with a dazed look on his face, his spirit broken.

"Hmph." Yuan didn't bother waiting for a response and decapitated him before burning all of their bodies, leaving behind their spatial rings and treasures.

"You guys can come out now." Yuan said out loud.

Tian Yanyu and Tian Xianzu came out of their hiding spot the following moment.

"You actually managed to kill all of them by yourself...?" Tian Xianzu was in disbelief, but the corpses before him were solid evidence that he could not refute.

Yuan nodded, and he asked, "Do you know how many assassins the Silent Rippers have? I killed 17— 18 if we consider the one from a few days ago."

Tian Xianzu pondered for a moment before responding, "Honestly, nobody knows the exact number, but according to the rumors, there should be about a hundred assassins within their group."

"A hundred?!" Yuan exclaimed.

"That's a very small group if you compare them to the other groups that have hundreds of not thousands of assassins." Tian Yanyu said.

"I guess that makes sense. Anyways, since there are still more than 80 assassins out there, we will continue this for a few more days to see their response." Yuan then said.

"Alright."

A few days later, Steward Jin was summoned again by the Silent Rippers. This time, they brought him to a secret location where over 50 of them were gathered.

"W-What is this about? If it's about the money, I have already paid the additional 10 million spirit stones!" Steward Jin said, his back soaked in sweat.

"Just who in heaven's name did you request us to kill?! 18 of our brothers and sisters are dead because of you!" The leader of the Silent Rippers roared at Steward Jin.

"What?! That's impossible!" Steward Jin felt his body becoming numb from shock after hearing this information.

"Impossible?! I dare you to tell me it's impossible again after seeing this!" The leader proceeded to place 18 broken life tablets on the table before them.

"T-This is..." Steward Jin swallowed nervously.

"Each of these represents one of our companions, and they all died on the same day within moments of each other! Tell me! Who is this Xiao Yang?! If you don't give us a satisfying answer, we will kill 18 people from the Lin Family!"

Steward Jin became terrified after hearing the leader's threats.

"I-I swear! I really don't know anything about him or his background! He showed up suddenly and started helping the Tian Family! He claimed that his ancestors owed a debt to the Tian Family and that he's there to repay that debt! I believed he was a nobody, but since we cannot touch the Tian

Family after what happened to the Stone Bandits, we decided to hire you guys to kill him to send a message!" Steward Jin revealed everything to the assassins.

The leader could tell that Steward Jin wasn't lying, but he was not satisfied with the answer.

"300 million spirit stones! You will compensate us for our companions' death and pay for our effort. This is the first time the Silent Rippers will be going all-out for a mission with all hands on deck."

"T-Three hundred million spirit stones?! That's too much! We don't have that much money!" Steward Jin nearly collapsed from shock after hearing this astronomical number.

"Don't fuck with me! The Lin Family is one of the Seven Legacy Families! You can definitely pay up! You can either pay us the money or we will kill people from the Lin Family! And we will consider each life to be worth 100,000 spirit stones, so we will kill 3,000 people in total!" The leader shouted.

"No way..." Steward Jin looked like he was in a dismay, and he regretted hiring the Silent Rippers immensely.

Chapter 1080 Dealing with the Silent Rippers(4)

Chapter 1080 Dealing with the Silent Rippers(4)

"I understand... I will pay 300 million spirit stones..." Steward Jin said.

However, he was inwardly hoping for these assassins to be killed by Yuan so that he won't have to pay them this astronomical amount of money.

Naturally, the Lin Family could pay 300 million spirit stone if they wanted, but this deal between Steward Jin and the Silent Rippers was not part of the Lin Family's decision. Only he and Lin Minghai were involved in this scandal, and if their family learns of this, they could be punished, especially considering the recent commotion.

Therefore, if he had to pay 300 million spirit stones, he had to do so without the Lin Family's help.

After returning to the Lin Family, Steward Jin told Lin Minghai of the situation.

When the Young Master of the Lin Family heard this unpleasant news, his face turned as pale as clean bedsheets, almost as if his blood had been drained.

"How could this have happened! 300 million spirit stones?! Where the fuck are we going to get that kind of money without asking for my family for help?!" Lin Minghai exclaimed, his face and back soaked in cold sweat.

"I-If this Xiao Yang somehow manages to kill the rest of the Silent Rippers, we won't have to pay them..." Steward Jin said in a weak voice.

"Are you fucking stupid?! You think he can handle the Silent Rippers all by himself?!"

"I mean, he's already killed 18 of them." Steward Jin said, clinging onto hope.

"I don't know what trick he's used to defeat so many assassins, but it will not happen a second time! Furthermore, the entire organization will be there this time! He's doomed to die!" Lin Minghai said, mostly because he didn't want to believe that they had offended someone powerful enough to defeat the Silent Rippers.

"Anyways, I think the best course of action is to wait and see what happens." Steward Jin said.

"If we're left with no choice, we will have to ask your family for help. I believe they will be more angry if 3,000 people in their family die because of us."

Lin Minghai sighed, "We have no choice since we won't be able to pay 300 million spirit stones even if I sold all of my treasures."

Later that night, 83 assassins surrounded the Tian Family's household.

"They are here." Feng Yuxiang warned Tian Yanyu and the others when she noticed their presence.

"How many are there?" Tian Xianzu asked.

"83 people. All of them are Spirit Kings, and 11 of them are peak Spirit Kings." Xiao Hua calmly said.

"E-Eleven peak Spirit Kings?!" Old Zou almost fell unconscious from shock after hearing this information.

"You stay here and protect them, phoenix. Xiao Hua will go with Brother Yuan just in case."

"Huh? Why do I have to stay here with them? Can't you do it? Or are you trying to earn points by yourself?" Feng Yuxiang looked at her with a suspicious gaze.

"I can protect them by myself." Lan Yingying suddenly said, "Since they're mostly targeting Yuan, they won't pay any attention to us."

"Thank you." Feng Yuxiang said to her before leaving the room with Xiao Hua.

However, they didn't immediately go to Yuan. Instead, they hid their presence and watched the situation from afar, as they wouldn't be interfering with Yuan unless he needed help.

Meanwhile, Yuan was already waiting in the courtyard for the assassins, and he has been cultivating there for the past few days.

"That's the bastard that killed 18 of our brothers and sisters? He looks so young!" One of the assassins was shocked when he saw Yuan's appearance.

"Don't be fooled by his appearance! He's a peak Spirit King! And his appearance might even be fake!" The leader of the Silent Rippers said to them using divine sense.

The Silent Rippers did not immediately approach Yuan, and they assessed the situation and surroundings to make sure this wasn't a trap, as it looked like one.

Sometime later, Yuan opened his eyes and spoke in a calm voice, "How long are you guys going to make me wait? If you're worried that this might be a trap, don't worry, I don't need such tactics to deal with you lot."

A gentle breeze swept the courtyard the following moment, and 83 figures appeared out of thin air like ghosts, all of them surrounding Yuan, their bodies exuding intense killing intent.

"I don't know who you are, but congratulations. You're the first to push our Silent Rippers to the edge." A bulky middle-aged man spoke in a grim

voice.

Yuan glanced at this man and smiled, "So you're the leader, huh?"

The leader frowned, "How can you tell?"

"It's not hard, especially considering that the atmosphere around you is vastly superior to the rest of the people here."

"That's right. I am the leader of the Silent Rippers, Zhan Shichai! Remember my name when you go to hell."

Ahd he continued, "Any last words before we take care of you?"

Yuan nodded, "Just one. Is this really the last of you guys? I don't want to wait around for more of you after killing everyone here."

"KILL HIM!" Zhan Shichai suddenly roared, and the 83 assassins there launched their attack at Yuan.

BOOM!

The entire courtyard exploded, and the whole street trembled the following moment.

However, Yuan remained unscathed, which shocked the assassins.

"This isn't good." Yuan didn't want the assassins to blow up the whole residence, so he attacked the assassins aggressively.

Using his movement technique, he traveled from one assassin to another in a single step, and every time he brandished his sword, a life from the Silent Rippers would perish.

Within minutes, the courtyard became dyed in red from the assassins' blood with their corpses and body parts littered everywhere.

The Silent Rippers became more terrified of Yuan as time passed, and they quickly realized that they had messed with the wrong person, but alas, it

was already too late for them to change their mind.

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Chapter 1081 Confronting the Lin Family

Chapter 1081 Confronting the Lin Family

Within minutes of the Silent Rippers showing up in the courtyard, Yuan had already killed half of them.

His movements were extremely fluid and decisive, and every single time he brandished his arm, one or more assassins would perish.

"T-This guy is a monster!"

"Leader, what should we do?! At this rate, he will completely obliterate us!"

The assassins turned to Zhan Shichai for help.

"He won't be able to keep that up forever! He must be using a tremendous amount of spiritual energy! It will only be a matter of time before his weakness shows! Keep pushing!" Zhan Shichai commanded as he tried to attack Yuan, but he couldn't even catch Yuan's shadow, much less reach him.

In the end, none of the assassins were able to harm Yuan.

"Hey, you're the only one left now." Yuan spoke as he looked at Zhan Shichai with a calm gaze.

Zhan Shichai, who was kneeling on the floor with a missing arm and multiple wounds on his body gritted his teeth in frustration, his gaze at Yuan filled with killing intent, yet he could not do anything about it.

"What are you waiting for? Hurry up and get this over with. Kill me already." Zhan Shichai had already given up all hopes of surviving this ordeal.

Yuan pondered for a moment before speaking, "No, I won't kill you."

"W-What?! Why not?!"

A voice that wasn't Zhan Shichai's voice suddenly resounded.

Yuan turned to look at Tian Yanyu, who had come out of hiding and was approaching them.

"Why won't you kill him? He's the leader of the Silent Rippers!"

"Because I still have some use for him," he said.

And he continued, "I'll give you a chance to live. Go report yourself to the authorities and let them know about your mission and how the Lin Family had hired you to kill me."

"You can go fuck yourself. I'd rather kill myself than to to give myself up." Zhan Shichai laughed out loud.

"Is that so?"

Yuan then turned to look at Tian Yanyu and asked, "Do you want to visit the Lin Family with me? You can stay here if you'd like."

"W-What do you mean by that? Are you going to the Lin Family right now?" Tian Yanyu's eyes widened with shock.

"That's right. If he's not going to give himself up, I will do it myself."

When Zhan Shichai heard Yuan's words, he immediately tried to explode his Dantian.

[Heaven Sealing Technique]

Yuan noticed this and sealed his cultivation before he could do anything.

"W-What did you just do to me?!" Zhan Shichai roared.

"I sealed your cultivation so you can't do anything stupid."

Hearing this, Zhan Shichai tried to bite his tongue off next.

However, when he opened his mouth, he found out that he couldn't close it back, almost as though there was something holding onto his mouth.

"Give it up. You won't die unless I let you." Yuan said.

He turned to look at the dumbfounded Tian Yanyu and asked again, "So? Are you coming?"

She quickly snapped out of her daze and nodded with a solemn expression on her face.

"Let go." Yuan grabbed Zhan Shichai by the neck before flying out of the resilience with Tian Yanyu.

Meanwhile, Feng Yuxiang and Xiao Hua entered his body with Lan Yingying staying behind just in case there were any more assassins.

"Bring me to the Lin Family." Yuan said to Tian Yanyu.

"Follow me."

It was at this moment a notification appeared before Yuan.

<Congratulations! You have subdued the Silent Rippers!>

<You have completed a Hidden Quest!>

<Fame +10,000>

<Due to your righteous actions, the Third Heaven will become a safer place for the innocent. Your reputation within the faction has increased

significantly!>

<Your faction rank has ranked up!>

[Faction Rank: Captain]

Sometime later, Yuan and Tian Yanyu arrived at the Lin Family's main household.

They descended in front of their front gates and said to the guards, "Bring your Patriarch out here. I have some questions for him."

"Who the hell are you? This isn't a place for children like you." The guards there immediately frowned.

"Scram before we make you."

Yuan lifted Zhan Shichai into the air and held him before the guards, and he spoke in a cold voice, "Your Lin Family hired assassinations to kill me. If you don't bring out your Patriarch, I will have to force him out."

"What?!" The guards exclaimed after hearing his claims.

"Outragous! Why would the Lin Family assassinate you?!"

"That's some serious accusations, boy! If you value your life, keep your mouth shut!"

Yuan sighed before speaking, "I will ask you again. Are you going to get your patriarch or not?" This chapter is updated by FreewebnOvel.com.

"Piss off!" The guard roared.

"Is that so?" A cold look appeared on Yuan's face.

He turned to look at Tian Yanyu and handed Zhan Shichai to her, "Stay back and watch over him for me."

"What are you going to do?" She had a bad feeling about this.

"Nothing much." He said with a smile.

After hanging Zhan Shichai to Tian Yanyu, Yuan turned to focus on the gates, and the next moment—

BOOM!

Yuan kicked down the entire gate, shocking the guards there.

"Y-You crazy bastard!"

"Intruder! Seize him!"

When the pedestrians there saw the scene, they stopped whatever they were doing to spectate.

"Who is this crazy bastard?! He dares to kick down the Lin Family's front gates?!"

"Heavens! He's even beating the guards down!"

More and more guards showed up to confront Yuan, but they were all beaten within seconds.

Eventually, the real experts showed up with their Spirit King aura filling the place.

"Halt! What do you think you are doing?! Identify yourself!"

Four Spirit Kings surrounded Yuan.

"My name is Xiao Yang, and I am here to speak with the Lin Family's patriarch." Yuan said, and he pointed at Tian Yanyu and Zhan Shichai and continued, "That half-dead man is the leader of the Silent Rippers, and he told me that the Lin Family had hired them to assassinate me. I am here to demand an answer from the Lin Family!"

Yuan spoke in a loud and clear voice so that everyone from one end of the street to the other could hear him.

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Chapter 1082 Confronting the Lin Family(2)

Chapter 1082 Confronting the Lin Family(2)

"What? The Lin Family hired those notorious assassins, the Silent Rippers?!"

The pedestrians outside the Lin Family were shocked when they heard this claim by Yuan.

"This must be due to what happened recently! Then that rumor must have been true—that the Lin Family hired those bandits to harass the Tian Family!"

"They must have hired the Silent Rippers to silence them. How vicious and cruel."

"I never knew the Lin Family were like this. What an eye opener."

The experts from the Lin Family frowned when they heard the pedestrian's words.

'Not good! At this rate, the Lin Family's reputation will hit rock bottom!' They all cried inwardly.

"There must have been a misunderstanding. The Lin Family did not hire the Silent Rippers." One of the experts said to Yuan.

"A misunderstanding? There are dozens of corpses in the Tian Family because of the Silent Rippers, and many of them claimed to have been hired

by the Lin Family. If you don't give an appropriate answer, I will have to stop being polite." Yuan calmly said.

"Stop being polite? You beat up our guards and spew nonsense in front of our building, yet you're still being polite? I cannot imagine what not being polite looks like!" The experts cursed.

"What are you all waiting for?! Hurry up and capture him!" One of the experts suddenly said.

The experts quickly surrounded Yuan when they heard this person, and just as they prepared to apprehend Yuan, he flipped his palms and showed these experts the symbols that suddenly appeared on it.

"Celestial Overlord Captain?" The experts raised their eyebrows in a puzzled manner when they saw these words hovering above Yuan's palm.

None of them recognized it.

However, somewhere within the Lin Family's building, an old man that had been watching the commotion through his divine sense suddenly snapped his eyelids open, his eyes filled with shock.

"That symbol! That's not possible! What is someone like him doing down here in the Third Heaven?!" This old man exclaimed, and without any hesitation, he rushed out of his room.

Meanwhile...

"What the hell are you trying to attempt?" One of the experts there asked Yuan after seeing the symbol but not recognizing it.

"You don't recognize it? I guess I gave you guys too much credit." Yuan shook his head when nobody there recognized the Celestial Overlord's faction symbol.

'This is why I didn't want to rely on this symbol. Nobody down here recognizes it.' He sighed inwardly.

"If you think those worthless words will save you, think again!" The experts made their movements.

"WAAAAAIT! HAAALT!"

However, before they could do anything, a loud voice echoed loudly, causing all of these experts to flinch and halt their movements.

When the experts turned around and saw the old man approaching them, their eyes widened with shock.

"S-Senior Lin!"

The experts there lowered their heads and bowed to him.

'Looks like someone actually recognizes the symbol.' Yuan smiled inwardly after seeing the situation.

Indeed, this old man recognized the Celestial Overlord's symbol. Even though he has never been in the upper heavens or seen their symbol before, he has at least heard about it.

In order to keep their descendants up to date about the situation in the upper heavens, these families in the upper heavens such as the Seven Legacy Families would send down the most information about the upper heavens down to their branch families in the lower heavens.

And as one of the top factions in the entire Nine Heavens, it would only make sense for these families in the upper heavens to include the Celestial Overlords.

Although the chances were slim to none, it was not impossible for someone from the Celestial Overlords to show up in the lower heavens, and these families were afraid of that minor chance happening, hence the precaution.

"All of you! Get on your knees and apologize to this Young Master!" The old man roared at the experts.

"What?!" The experts and all of the spectators there were shocked speechless after hearing the old man's words.

"Did you not hear me?! It's either that or your heads will roll on the floor!" The old man shouted again.

The experts trembled in fear, and they quickly kowtowed to Yuan the following moment while feeling completely baffled and puzzled by the situation.

"W-We apologize!"

The old man then turned to look at the guards and shouted, "You bastards as well! Kowtow and apologize to the Young Master!"

If the experts had the kowtow to Yuan, these guards naturally had to follow, and unless they were unconscious, these guards got on their knees and kowtowed to Yuan, "We apologize!"

The spectators there wondered what Yuan's real identity was for these people from the Lin Family to kowtow to him.

"Young Master, please forgive these fools for not recognizing your identity. They have never seen the real Mount Tai before, so they don't know any better." The old man said to him with a humble look on his face.

Yuan calmly looked at him and asked, "Who are you?"

"This humble one is named Lin Chunhua. I was the previous Patriarch of the Lin Family. In other words, I am the current Patriarch's father. I understand that something unfortunate has happened to the Tian Family recently. Why don't we go talk somewhere more appropriate?"

"Sure." Yuan nodded.

He turned to look at Tian Yanyu and beckoned for her.

Tian Yanyu swallowed nervously before approaching him.

'The ancestor of the Lin Family is acting so respectful to him... Just what is his true identity? Did his ancestors really owe the Tian Family? Why is he helping our Tian Family?'

So many questions appeared in Tian Yanyu's head as she followed Yuan and the old man into the Lin Family's household.

Meanwhile, the pedestrians there scattered to spread the news, sending shockwaves throughout the city.

An unknown individual had kicked down the Lin Family's door, and not only did he not get tortured to death, but he was even politely escorted into the Lin Family's household by their retired Patriarch.

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Chapter 1083 Confronting the Lin Family(3)

Chapter 1083 Confronting the Lin Family(3)

After being escorted into the Lin Family's best guest room, Lin Chunhua gestured for them to take a seat at the luxurious couches.

"I will make some tea for us." Lin Chunhua said after they sat down.

But Yuan waved his hand and said, "There's no need. Let's get straight to the point. Your Lin Family had hired assassins— the Silent Rippers to assassinate me. The proof is over there."

He pointed at the half-dead man in Tian Yanyu's grasp.

Lin Chunhua looked at Zhan Shichai with a deep frown on his face.

"Why do you think my Lin Family hired them? While I admit that we sometimes go overboard, we would never ask assassins for help, especially not the Silent Rippers."

"They said so themselves, and it's too much of a coincidence for this to happen after what we did to the Stone Bandits."

"If what you say is true, then I will investigate this situation and bring out the perpetrator and compensate you for the trouble. However, before I do that, I must notify the current Patriarch of the Lin Family about the situation and see what he has to say."

Lin Chunhua retrieved a communication jade slip and mumbled into it.

"While we wait for him to show up, I have a few questions, if you don't mind."

"Go ahead."

"You're a member of the esteemed Celestial Overlords— a Captain at that. Am I correct?"

"Indeed." Yuan nodded.

'Celestial Overlords? What is that? A sect?' Tian Yanyu wondered inwardly, as she has never heard of such a place before in her entire life.

"What is someone of your prestigious stature doing down here in the Third Heaven? If you don't feel comfortable telling me, I completely understand."

"My ancestor owed a debt to the Tian Family, but he is no longer able to repay that debt, hence why I am here." Yuan explained.

"Is that so... The Tian Family, huh?" The old man turned to look at Tian Yanyu, who was quite nervous at this moment.

"To be honest with you, I usually spend most of my time in seclusion trying to break through to Spirit Emperor, so I don't know much about the situation outside the Lin Family, and even the situation within the family isn't very clear to me, as it has been over a hundred years since I last left seclusion." Lin Chunhua explained.

And he continued, "If my Lin Family has done anything wrong while I was away, I will personally step in to fix it. I swear."

"That's good to hear." Yuan calmly said.

A few minutes later, the door slammed open when a middle-aged man rushed into the room.

"Father! What happened?! What's the emergency?! For you to come out unannounced and so suddenly—"

"Shut up!" Lin Chunhua suddenly roared.

"You useless son, get your ass over here!"

The middle-aged man was speechless. How could his father treat him in such a manner before guests? His father was someone who valued face more than anything, yet he was doing something that would lower the Lin Family's face.

However, he could tell that his father was enraged, so he didn't dare to question it. Follow current novels on FreewebNovel.com.

After closing the door, the Patriarch of the Lin Family walked to stand beside Lin Chunhua.

"I will ask you a question and you will answer me truthfully. If you dare lie before my face, I will have you replaced." Lin Chunhua said, causing Patriarch Lin to swallow nervously.

As the strongest cultivator in the Lin Family and being the previous Patriarch, Lin Chunhua still had immense authority within the Lin Family, so he could very well do what he threatened to do.

"Did you— the Lin Family hire assassins to assassinate this Young Master here? The Silent Rippers, no less."

"What?! That's outrageous! We would never do such a thing!"

"Then how do you explain that?" Lin Chunhua pointed at the half-dead Zhan Shichai.

Patriarch Lin turned to look at Zhan Shichai.

Although he didn't recognize Zhan Shichai at first due to his swollen face and overall bad condition, he would eventually recognize him.

"Isn't that the leader of the Silent Rippers, Zhan Shichai?! What is he doing here?!"

"According to the Young Master, he raided the Tian Family at the request of the Lin Family. However, he was subdued and the Silent Rippers were exterminated by the Young Master instead." Lin Chunhua said.

"Young Master...?" Patriarch Lin was utterly gobsmacked when he realized how respectful his father was to this young man.

This is the first time Lin Chunhua has shown such respect for a junior like Yuan.

"I apologize for the late introduction. I am Lin Xingmy, the current Patriarch of the Lin Family." Patriarch Lin said to Yuan, but he clearly wasn't taking Yuan as seriously as his father.

"Xiao Yang. This is who I am." Yuan showed the Celestial Overlord's symbol for a second time.

Patriarch Lin raised his eyebrows in a puzzled manner when he saw Yuan's action.

"What is—" He suddenly halted his words midway through his sentence, and his eyes widened with shock.

"T-That's... Are you from the Celestial Overlords?!" Patriarch Lin exclaimed when he remembered reading about it.

"I am." He calmly nodded.

Patriarch Lin finally understood why his father came out of seclusion so suddenly and why he was being so respectful to Yuan.

Although the Lin Family is one of Seven Legacy Families and incredibly influential within their world, their family's influence actually becomes weaker the higher they go in the Nine Heavens, and above the 5th heavens, they are no different than a middle-class family.

Meanwhile, the Celestial Overlords are a peak faction in the Supreme Heaven, which is the peak of the Nine Heavens. The difference between the

Celestial Overlords and the Seven Legacy Families was akin to heaven and earth— they were simply incomparable.

"Please forgive me for not recognizing your identity sooner, Young Master!" Patriarch Lin began addressing him as Young Master as well.

'No way...' Tian Yanyu muttered inwardly.

Not in a million years could she have imagined such a situation would occur.

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Chapter 1084 Confronting the Lin Family(4)

Chapter 1084 Confronting the Lin Family(4)

"Rest assured, Young Master. I will find the culprit who hired the Silent Rippers to bother you no matter how long it will take! And if it truly turns out to be someone from my Lin Family, I will immediately have him executed no matter his identity!" Patriarch Lin said with a serious expression on his face after learning of Yuan's identity and the immense background behind him.

Yuan nodded with a satisfied look on his face, "How long do you think it will take?"

"Two— No, I will have it done within a week!" Patriarch Lin assured him in a confident voice.

"Then I will return to this place in a week. I hope you will have sorted everything out by then."

Yuan stood up and turned to look at Tian Yanyu and said, "Let's go. You can leave that man behind for the Lin Family to interrogate."

"Y-Yes!" She snapped out of her daze and handed the leader of the Silent Rippers over to Patriarch Lin.

"He'll try to kill himself, so make sure you don't let that happen." Yuan warned them before making his way to the exit.

Neither Lin Chunhua or Patriarch Lin dared to stop him. In fact, they wanted him to leave as soon as possible, as his presence was simply too

heavy for them.

Once Yuan's presence could no longer be felt, Lin Chunhua turned to look at his son and spoke in a grim voice, "Do not mess this up! The Celestial Overlords are a top faction within the Supreme Heaven! A single mistake and we could be wiped out, and not even our family in the upper heaven would be able to do a thing!"

"Moreover, the Celestial Overlords are known to be a righteous faction, so if it's true that someone from our family hired assassins such as the notorious Silent Rippers to kill him, they have every right to destroy us!"

"I am well aware of our situation." Patriarch Lin spoke with a deep frown on his face.

"Are you sure you know?! If you had kept an eye on the family properly, none of this would've happened! I went into closed cultivation for a hundred years and you messed everything up! How will I ever be able to enter closed cultivation with a peace of mind now, you useless son?!"

"I'm really sorry, father... I have let you down—"

"No! You let the Lin Family down!" Lin Chunhua shouted.

"I'm going to do my own investigations because I cannot trust you to handle this by yourself!"

Over the next several hours, the Lin Family would become incredibly busy with people scrambling around like ants.

Meanwhile, news of what happened outside the Lin Family spread throughout the city like wildfire, shocking everyone.

"What?! The Lin Family hired the Silent Rippers to assassinate the Tian Family?! So the rumors were true! They must have tried to silence the Tian Family!"

"Heavens! How low the Lin Family has fallen!"

The situation with the Lin Family had gotten so bad that the other legacy families had sent people to speak with Patriarch Lin. However, they were all turned away without any explanations.

"What the hell is the Lin Family doing? We're in the middle of something important and they're messing around with assassins?!"

"Unbelievable. This will surely affect our reputation as well."

The other legacy families were not happy about the situation, especially since they will definitely be dragged into such a scandal.

Moreover, they were in the middle of hunting a wanted criminal, and this would only make things more difficult for everyone.

However, there was nothing they could do about it except wait for the Lin Family to fix it.

Meanwhile, after leaving the Lin Family, Yuan and Tian Yanyu made their way back to the Tian Family.

But shortly before they arrived, another person would arrive at the Tian Family.

"Mistress! What are you doing here?!" Old Zou was shocked to see her.

"Is it true?! That my daughter started something with the Lin Family?!" Tian Suyin asked in a nervous manner.

"Starting something? We're far past that point." Tian Xianzu's voice suddenly resounded.

"You! What do you mean by those words?! What happened?! Where's Yanyu right now?!" Tian Suyin glared at her husband with an enraged look on her face.

"What happened, you ask? The Lin Family had hired the Silent Rippers to silence us. As for Yanyu, she's currently at the Lin Family with—"

ap!

Tian Xianzu suddenly felt something slap him across his face.

"What in heaven's name are you doing?! I left Yanyu in your care because I trusted that you would protect her! And why the hell are you so calm about this?!"

"..."

Tian Xianzu didn't utter a single word and accepted the slap, as he felt that he'd deserved it for not being able to stop Tian Yanyu from going to war with the Lin Family.

And right as he prepared to explain the whole situation to his wife, another voice resounded, "Mother? What are you doing here?"

It was Tian Yanyu, and she'd just returned with Yuan.

"Y-Yanyu! Are you okay?! Did the Lin Family do anything to you?!" Tian Suyin rushed over to her daughter.

'That's her mother, huh?' Yuan looked at the beautiful woman standing before Tian Yanyu.

Not only did Tian Yanyu resemble her mother, but they looked almost like sisters with the mother being several years older.

"I'm fine, mother. What about you? Did something happen at the sect? Why did you suddenly return?"

"I returned because of you! I have warned you many times to not mess with the Lin Family and what do you do when I leave you alone for a bit? You mess with the Lin Family! Now they're sending the most notorious assassins in the Third Heaven—the Silent Rippers—to our residence! We need to get you out of here before they kill you!"

Tian Yanyu took a step back and quickly said, "C-Calm down, mother. The situation isn't as dire as you think, really."

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Chapter 1085 Familiar Sword Technique

Chapter 1085 Familiar Sword Technique

"Isn't that dire?! Are you seriously saving that?! We are currently being hunted by the Silent Rippers! Not even my sect can protect us from them! And what about the Lin Family?! They will surely try to do something as well!" Tian Suyin exclaimed with a heated expression on her face.

"Just take a moment to calm down while I explain." Tian Yanyu sighed, and she continued, "First of all, the Silent Rippers are no longer a threat to us. They've already been dealt with, and their leader was even captured."

"W-What?" Tian Suyin's eyes widened with shock upon hearing this information.

The notorious Silent Rippers have been dealt with? Their leader was captured? By whom? Who could possibly be strong enough to do such a thing?

And before Tian Suyin could ask these questions, Tian Yanyu pointed at the handsome young man standing behind her and spoke, "Meet Xiao Yang. He's the one who helped us deal with the Silent Rippers."

Tian Suyin turned to look at Yuan. Although she had noticed his presence, she didn't even bother looking at him as she had more important things to care about.

However, when she saw Yuan's handsome face, she became quite startled, mostly because Yuan looked almost like her daughter.

Although neither Tian Yanyu nor Tian Xianzu noticed the similarities, Tian Suyin noticed it at glance.

"W-Who are you?" Tian Suyin asked him after snapping out of her daze.

"My name is Xian Yang, and I came here to repay a debt my ancestors owed to your ancestors." Yuan said with a friendly smile on his face.

Tian Suyin immediately frowned, as she didn't buy his excuse, and he simply looked too suspicious, especially his appearance.

"Are you the reason my Tian Family got entangled with the Lin Family and the Silent Rippers?" Tian Suyin had a feeling this was the situation and asked him for confirmation.

"The Tian Family and the Lin Family had already been tangled with each other even before my arrival. I am simply trying to untangle it."

"Really?" Tian Suyin spoke with a doubtful look on her face, "How do I know that you weren't sent here by the Lin Family? We've been handling our situation with the Lin Family just fine before your help, but look at how things turned out when you showed up!"

"How things turned out?" Yuan raised an eyebrow.

And he continued, "If you're talking about the Silent Rippers, I have already taken care of them, and the leader is being interrogated by the Lin Family. As for the Lin Family themselves, they have agreed to find the person responsible for hiring the Silent Rippers."

"You dare to tell me that you, a mere Spirit King, managed to deal with the Silent Rippers that are known to have multiple Spirit Kings? Your farts are getting louder and louder, brat." The frown on Tian Suyin's face burrowed even deeper.

"He's telling the truth." Tian Xianzu suddenly spoke.

"I watched him do it, after all."

"That's right! Xiao Yang is extremely powerful and talented! He can handle multiple Spirit Kings by himself!" Tian Yanyu jumped in to defend Yuan.

"..."

Tian Suyin turned silent for a good moment after hearing her husband and daughter's words.

"If you're truly as powerful as they claim, I want to see it for myself."

"You want to spar with me?" Yuan raised an eyebrow.

"Yes. I have to confirm for myself your strength, after all."

"I don't suggest doing that, mother... Xiao Yang... He's really powerful..."
Tian Yanyu said with a worried look on her face.

"Shut up. I don't care if he's the strongest cultivator in the Nine Heavens. Unless I see it for myself, I won't believe it."

"If that's what it will take for you to calm down." Yuan nodded with a confident look on his face.

They entered the courtyard shortly after.

"I don't want to damage my own home, so let's put up a defensive array first." Tian Suyin said.

"You're an Array Master?" Yuan asked.

"No, I am." Tian Xianzu suddenly said.

"I'm a Level 4 Array Master," he continued.

"Really? I'm actually a Level 2 Array Master myself." Yuan smiled.

"Seriously? You're also an Array Master? Is there anything you can't do?"
Tian Yanyu asked with a baffled look on her face.

Sometime later, Tian Xianzu covered the courtyard in a defensive array.

However, since he created it in a hurry, the defensive array wasn't anything impressive and actually quite fragile.

When Yuan saw this, he said, "Are you sure this is enough? It won't last even a single attack."

"It'll be fine. It's not like we're trying to kill each other." Tian Suyin nodded.

"Then whenever you're ready. I won't be using any spiritual techniques to make this fair." Yuan said with a calm smile.

Tian Suyin's eyebrows twitched slightly upon hearing his words that sounded like he was underestimating her.

And without warning, she rushed at him with her fists ready to strike.

Seeing this, Yuan began dodging her strikes, making it seem as though they were dancing around the courtyard.

Eventually, Tian Suyin retrieved her sword and started attacking Yuan with even more intensity.

Tian Suyin did not want to use any techniques at first since she didn't want to damage her home, but she was feeling irritated about the fact that she couldn't even land a single strike on a junior like Yuan, so she started unleashing sword techniques at him.

'These sword techniques...'

For some reason, Yuan could feel a sense of familiarity from Tian Suyin's sword techniques even though this is his first time seeing it, and the more he looked at it the stronger this feeling got.

It quickly got to the point where he was no longer focused on the fight but the sword techniques instead.

'Why am I feeling this sense of familiarity from her sword techniques? Is it related to one of my past lives?' He couldn't help but ponder about this possibility.

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Chapter 1086 Lin Family's Gathering

Chapter 1086 Lin Family's Gathering

"Are you mocking me?!" Tian Suyin suddenly stopped moving and shouted at Yuan, who had been completely focused on her sword techniques.

"Huh? What are you talking about?" He snapped out of his daze and asked.

"You've been doing nothing but avoid me! Are we playing tag or are we fighting?!" She pointed her sword at him, and on her face was an angry frown.

"Oh, sorry. I was distracted by something." Yuan said with an apologetic smile on his face.

And he asked, "By the way, before we continue, can I ask you a question? Where did you learn that sword technique?"

"If you beat me, I will tell you." Tian Suyin sneered.

"Very well."

Yuan gave Tian Suyin a moment to prepare herself.

Once it seemed like she was ready, Yuan suddenly disappeared from Tian Suyin's vision even though she had been staring at him without blinking, almost like he'd disappeared into thin air.

She suddenly felt a presence appear behind her, and she instinctively turned around while swinging her sword.

Yuan calmly moved his hand behind her elbow, preventing her from turning around any further, and with his other hand, he gave her one good punch on the side of her stomach.

"Ah!" Tian Suyin released a painful cry before falling to her knees.

Even though it seemed like an ordinary punch, the punch actually shook the spiritual energy in Tian Suyin's Dantian like a shockwave, forcing her body to feel weak, temporarily losing all of her strength.

"I think the disparity between you and I should be quite clear now." Yuan said to her as he lowered his fist, letting them rest beside him.

Tian Suyin gritted her teeth in frustration. She was a sect elder of a relatively strong sect, yet she couldn't even touch a single hair on Yuan's body, who was many years younger than her. And to make matters worse, she wielded a weapon and used techniques while Yuan confronted her with his bare hands.

Although Tian Suyin couldn't fully grasp Yuan's strength from their light spar, one thing was clear, and that Yuan was a formidable individual.

"What did I tell you, mother? Xiao Yang is the real deal. And what he showed you just now isn't even a small fraction of his full strength." Tian Yanyu shook her head at her mother.

"To be fair, your mother didn't use her full strength either. Well, I think she just wanted to understand my strength even if it's a little." Yuan said, hoping it'd make Tian Suyin feel better.

Once the spiritual energy inside her body stabilized, Tian Suyin stood up and spoke in a low voice, "Sword of Indomitable Will. That's the name of the sword technique I used, and it's a technique from the Jade Sword Manor. Although it's a relatively weak sword technique, I learned it because I liked its name."

"Sword of Indomitable Will..." Yuan mumbled this name in a low voice.

"I am actually a disciple of this sect, and I also know this sword technique, by the way." Tian Yanyu suddenly said.

"Is that so..."

After pondering for a moment, he asked, "Do you mind if I visit the Jade Sword Manor?"

"Why would you want to do that?" Tian Yanyu asked.

"I want to confirm something." He said, giving a vague answer.

Tian Yanyu realized this so she didn't ask further.

"No." Tian Suyin suddenly said, and she continued, "Until you settle your business with the Lin Family and this situation, you're not going anywhere. I don't want you bringing trouble into our sect."

Yuan nodded, "Don't worry, it'll all be settled in a few days."

"Anyways, I'm going to rest for a bit. If you need me, you know where to find me." Yuan said to them before going back to his room.

Once Yuan was gone, Tian Suyin turned to look at Tian Yanyu and said with a solemn face, "You're going to tell me everything from the beginning! And don't you dare miss even the slightest detail!"

"I understand..."

Thus, the Tian Family went to another room for their meeting.

Meanwhile, at the Lin Family, all of its members had been gathered in one place under Patriarch Lin's instructions.

"I wonder what happened. I can't even recall the last time Father gathered all of us in such a manner." A young lady mumbled out loud to the others around her.

"It probably has something to do with what happened very recently."
Another person said.

"What happened?"

"According to what my servant told me, some crazy bastard kicked down our Lin Family's front gate and even beat many of our guards."

"What?! Which madman would dare to do such a thing?"

"Even if that did happen, why would the Patriarch summon all of us?"

"I heard that Ancestor Lin also came out of his seclusion recently."

"The Ancestor?! Does this mean he's finally breakthrough to the Spirit Emperor realm?!"

"Silence!" A loud voice suddenly resounded, instantly hushing the room.

Then, the sound of footsteps resounded.

A few moments later, Patriarch Lin appeared before them.

Patriarch Lin swept his gaze at the tens of thousands of people in front of him and said in a clear voice, "I want the names of those who could not make it today on my desk by tonight."

"Yes!" An old man immediately responded in a loud voice.

After a moment of silence, Patriarch Lin continued, "I have gathered all of you here today for two reasons."

"First of all, the upper heavens have decided to send people down here to look for the sinner that had received Heaven's death sentence, and it's not just a few people. According to the information I was given by the Lin Family in the upper heavens, thousands of people from all sorts of terrifying backgrounds that far surpasses our Lin Family's will be sent down here in a month or so."

Everyone there expressed great shock after hearing this information, as this was an unprecedented event that could shake up the entire Nine Heavens.

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Chapter 1087 Lin Family's Gathering(2)

Chapter 1087 Lin Family's Gathering(2)

"Now this shouldn't even need to be said, but I will still say it just in case. These people coming from the upper heavens are NOT to be trifled with. Many of them come from backgrounds that could easily wipe out our Lin Family and get off scot-free." Patriarch Lin said with a serious expression on his face.

"If you encounter one of these people, you will give them your utmost respect and treat them as if they are your own ancestors. Most of them will have their cultivation suppressed to peak Spirit King, and they will all be wearing a special badge on their clothes that will distinguish them from the others."

Patriarch Lin proceeded to show them a golden badge that was shaped into the word 'Heaven', which could also be read as 'Tian'.

"While I said that these people will come down in a month, in reality, some of them could have already made it down here for all we know."

Unbeknownst to the Lin Family, Patriarch Lin had received the news about the people from the upper heaven literally right before he showed up to the gathering, so he was just as surprised as everyone there.

And in his mind, the young man from the Celestial Overlords was part of this expedition team.

'How fucking unlucky for our Lin Family to offend someone from the upper heaven right before the news even spread.' He sighed inwardly.

"Now then, let's move onto our second topic and the main reason why I gathered all of you here today." Patriarch Lin spoke a moment later.

The Lin Family was baffled after hearing this, and they all wondered what could be even more important than the upper heavens sending people to their small world.

A scary expression suddenly appeared on Patriarch Lin's face, and his eyes emanated with killing intent, "As some of you have probably heard by now, there is a rumor going around that claims our Lin Family had hired the Silent Rippers to mess with the Tian Family."

"What? Such a thing happened?"

"My god..."

The people there were shocked to hear this, as if such a rumor was true, this could very well be a death sentence for whoever caused this trouble.

Meanwhile, within the crowd was Lin Minghai and Steward Jin, and both of them were sweating profusely at this moment.

The two of them exchanged worried glances with each other. If Patriarch Lin learns the truth, not even the Heavens would know of the aftermath.

'I really hope that you'd erased all evidence that could indicate us as the culprits...' Lin Minghai stared at Steward Jin in the eyes.

Steward Jin returned the stare with a confident look in his eyes, 'Don't worry, Young Master, there's no way they know that we were responsible.'

Patriarch Lin's voice resounded again, "To tell you the truth, I already know the culprits behind this incident."

'What?!' Lin Minghai and Steward Jin snapped their heads to look at Patriarch Lin with looks of disbelief on their faces.

"Bring him in!" Patriarch Lin suddenly shouted.

A few moments later, two peak Spirit King experts approached Patriarch Lin while pulling on a chain that was restricting a heavily injured individual.

This person was so badly beaten that his entire body was covered in bruises. It was clear as day that this individual had been tortured to a great extent, but nobody there said a word about it.

"Do you know who this man is?" Patriarch Lin asked them.

The Lin Family quickly shook their heads.

"What if I told you that his name is Zhan Shichai? Do you recognize him now?"

"Zhan Shichai?! Isn't that the leader of the Silent Rippers' name?! I have heard it before!" Someone there exclaimed.

"Indeed, this person is the leader of the Silent Rippers— or should I say was?" Patriarch Lin confirmed, sending another wave of shock throughout the Lin Family.

Patriarch Lin looked at the pitiful-looking Zhan Shichai and smiled, "No matter how strong you think you are— you will never be able to beat someone from the upper heavens, as we're akin to ants before their eyes."

Patriarch Lin's words implied several things. One, that Zhan Shichai was beaten by someone from the upper heavens. Two, that the Silent Rippers are no longer in operation. And lastly, that people from the upper heavens are already in the Third Heaven. Not everyone noticed these implications, but those that did were greatly shocked.

"Although it took some effort, I was able to extract a lot of information from Zhan Shichai, the former leader of the Silent Rippers, including the names of the people who hired them. However, I will give the culprits a chance to step forward and admit their mistakes. If you do so, I will lessen

the punishment." Patriarch Lin spoke in a loud and clear voice, but he had just spoken two lies just now.

First of all, no matter how much they tortured Zhan Shichai, they were unable to extract any information from him. Secondly, they did not know the culprits behind this whole fiasco.

In other words, Patriarch Lin was bluffing to trick the culprits into revealing themselves.

This was a cheap and sly tactic, but it was effective and Patriarch Lin had no time to spare. After all, the quicker he deals with this situation the more likely that Yuan wouldn't wipe the Lin Family from the face of this world.

Lin Minghai and Steward Jin looked at each other again, and on their faces showed absolute despair and desperation.

'Steward Jin, you fucking useless bastard!' Lin Minghai cried inwardly, silently cursing his most reliable servant, something he has never done before.

'What the hell is happening?! Even if that Xiao Yang had help from the Tian Family, they shouldn't have the capability to defeat the Silent Rippers, much less capture their leader, Zhan Shichai!' Steward Jin had a hysterical look on his face from being unable to comprehend the situation, and he felt so weak that he was on the verge of collapsing on the spot.

Chapter 1088 The Man Responsible

After a moment of silence, Patriarch Lin spoke in a booming voice, "Thirty seconds! The ones responsible for putting our Lin Family in this situation have thirty seconds to get up here and admit to their crimes! If you do so, we will spare you from the death penalty!"

"The death penalty?!" Lin Minghai cried inwardly. He could've never expected things to get out of control so quickly, nor could he have anticipated such a severe punishment.

"That bastard came from the upper heavens? No wonder why he dares to act so brazenly!" Steward Jin gritted his teeth in fear.

However, he wasn't completely hopeless, as he had made some preparations just in case this kind of situation would happen.

"Ten seconds left!" Patriarch Lin's voice rippled in the room, causing the walls to tremble slightly.

"Five... Four... Three—"

"I did it! It was me! I was the one who hired the Silent Rippers!" A clear voice suddenly resounded, and everyone in the room turned to look at the person who just spoke.

This person began making his way towards the front of the room.

Once he was before Patriarch Lin, the middle-aged man kneeled and kissed the floor with his forehead.

"This lowly servant is responsible for the mess. Please punish me as you see fit, Patriarch."

Patriarch Lin narrowed his eyes at the middle-aged man before him with a pondering face.

A moment of silence later, he spoke, "I don't recognize you. Identify yourself."

It wasn't weird for Patriarch Lin to not recognize the face of every servant in the Lin Family due to the sheer number of them.

"This lowly servant is called Wu Jie. I have been a servant of the Lin Family for 15 years now."

"Why did you hire the Silent Rippers?"

"Because it felt like the right thing to do, especially after their attempt to smear the Lin Family's name and reputation by associating us with the bandits." Wu Jie explained in a calm voice.

"Your foolish actions have done far more damage than any rumors could." Patriarch Lin shook his head.

Patriarch Lin actually could tell by the way Wu Jie acted that he wasn't the true culprit, but he couldn't care less and only wanted someone to take the fall and face Yuan's wrath, and the Lin Family wouldn't lose out on anything by losing a single servant.

"Follow me."

Patriarch Lin turned around and walked out of the room, followed by Wu Jie.

Once Patriarch Lin was gone and the atmosphere returned to normal, the others could finally take a breather.

Lin Minghai immediately approached Steward Jin and asked him in a low voice, "W-What the hell just happened?"

"I will explain it later. Let's go elsewhere first, Young Master."

"Alright."

They left the room and went somewhere more private.

"Who was that Wu Jie? Why did he admit to something he did not commit?" Lin Minghai asked with a puzzled look on his face.

A cold smile appeared on Steward Jin's face as he spoke, "A lowly servant... It's not hard to make them do things."

Lin Minghai stared at Steward Jin in a dazed manner for a moment before he burst out laughing, "You're evil, but I really appreciate what you've done for us, Steward Jin! I don't even want to imagine what could've happened to us if you didn't do such a thing!"

"I will do anything to keep you safe, Young Master." Steward Jin continued to smile.

And for the next few days, Patriarch Lin would keep Wu Jie locked up in their private prison until the day Yuan returned to their household.

A few days later.

"Alright, it's about time I check up on the Lin Family. You don't have to come with me if you don't want to." Yuan said to Tian Yanyu as he walked to their front gate.

"I am coming with you." Tian Yanyu insisted with a stern-looking expression on her face.

"I am also coming with you, and this is not up for debate.." Tian Suyin suddenly said.

"If my daughter and wife are going, I can't stay behind now, can I?" Tian Xianzu sighed.

Yuan smiled. "The more the merrier."

Thus, Yuan and the entire Tian Family began making their way to the Lin Family, attracting much attention from the pedestrians they passed as they got closer to their destination.

News of the Tian Family confronting the Lin Family quickly began spreading throughout the entire city like wildfire.

When the other Legacy Families heard the news, they began paying more attention to the situation.

Although the Tian Family was too small to attract their interest, they wanted to see how the Lin Family was going to handle the situation, as the recent rumors have really tanked their reputation within the city.

When Yuan and the Tian Family arrived at the Lin Family's front gate, the Lin Family was already waiting for them outside.

"Welcome back to our humble estate, Young Master." Lin Chunhua greeted him with a bright smile.

"Let's cut to the chase. Have you found the person who is responsible?" Yuan asked.

Tian Suyin and Tian Xianzu were on the verge of a nervous breakdown when they saw how Yuan behaved before the Lin Family.

Lin Chunhua turned to look at Patriarch Lin, who nodded and said, "We have found the man responsible for hiring the Silent Rippers. Before we punish him, we'd like to give you the chance to do so."

"Let's go somewhere more private, shall we?" Lin Chunhua asked him.

"Sure." Yuan nodded.

They proceeded to enter the Lin Family's estate.

Patriarch Lin brought Yuan and the Tian Family to their largest guest room and said to them, "I have already requested for the perpetrator to be transported here. Please give us a few minutes."

"I understand." Yuan nodded.

Tian Xianzu and Tian Suyin almost couldn't believe what they were witnessing right now.

'Am I dreaming or something? There's no way the Lin Family is acting this respectful to us... No, to him...' Tian Suyin glanced at Yuan with a pondering gaze.

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Chapter 1089 The Man Responsible(2)

'I knew he was someone special, but to think he was this special...' Tian Xianzu swallowed nervously as he sat in the Lin Family's guest room.

Both Tian Xianzu and Tian Suyin held their breaths as they waited for the Lin Family to bring in the 'culprit'.

A few minutes later, a middle-aged man with a somewhat blank look on his face was escorted into the room while his hands and legs were chained, and he appeared to have been beaten quite badly.

"This servant is Wu Jie, and he claimed responsibility for hiring the Silent Rippers. His reason being the recent rumors that have been spreading about our Lin Family. In other words, he wanted revenge." Patriarch Lin said.

Yuan narrowed his eyes at Wu Jie, causing him to tremble.

"Xiao Yang... I don't think he's the culprit..." Tian Yanyu whispered in his ears.

Even she could tell at glance that this servant wasn't responsible for it.

"Take a seat." Yuan gestured for Wu Jie to sit before them.

Wu Jie didn't dare to get comfortable, but Lin Chunhua insisted, "If the Young Master tells you to take a seat, you will take a seat."

Wu Jie quickly nodded his head and walked to the chair in small steps.

Once he was seated, Yuan retrieved the Grail of Truth and placed it on the table.

"I will now ask you several questions, and you will answer them truthfully." Yuan said to him.

Wu Jie nodded.

"Is your name Wu Jie?" Yuan asked a moment later.

"Yes..."

The Grail of Truth remained still.

"Did Patriarch Lin or Ancestor Lin force you to be here and play the role of culprit?"

"N-No! They did not!" Wu Jie said in a nervous voice.

Seeing no reaction from the Grail of Truth, Yuan continued, "Are you really the person responsible for hiring the Silent Rippers?"

"Yes, I am responsible." Wu Jie spoke with a somewhat defeated look on his face.

The Grail of Truth immediately pulsated with light.

Yuan smiled and said, "You're lying to me."

Wu Jie's eyes widened with shock, and he roared, "N-No! I am not lying! I swear that I am responsible! I was the one who hired the Silent Rippers to attack the Tian Family!"

The light coming from the Grail of Truth only became brighter as Wu Jie lied more.

"What is the meaning of th—" Lin Chunhua tried to question Wu Jie, but Yuan stopped him with a simple gesture.

"Please, allow me to ask him the questions."

"Alright..." Lin Chunhua stepped back and began glaring at Patriarch Lin with a threatening glare, causing him to swallow nervously.

"Why are you lying? Why would you claim responsibility for something you didn't do? Who are you trying to cover for?" Yuan asked Wu Jie, who could only silently shake his head now because he knew that his lies would be exposed if he uttered even a single word.

"Either you're so incredibly loyal to the person you're trying to protect that you'd be willing to sacrifice your life for them, or you're being forced to do so. Which is it?" Yuan asked.

"Please... I am really responsible... you have to believe me..." Wu Jie spoke in a low voice, sounding as though he was on the verge of crying.

Yuan turned to look at Lin Chunhua and spoke in a cold voice, "What is the meaning of this? Do you think I am foolish enough to believe this farce, or did you expect me to just accept it as it is?"

"Neither!" Lin Chunhua roared.

He approached Wu Jie and continued, "I will swear upon my surname and soul that I will protect you from whoever you're trying to protect. Tell us—why are you lying?"

"I will also guarantee your safety." Patriarch Lin suddenly added.

Upon hearing these words, Wu Jie immediately broke out in tears and bawled his eyes out.

"My family was taken from me! My wife and my daughter are taken as hostages! They told me that if I don't take the blame they would sell my wife and daughter to the worst brothels in the city!" Wu Jie cried out loud.

Lin Chunhua gritted his teeth in anger upon hearing this information.

"Which bastard within the Lin Family dares to do something so vile?! Tell me!" He roared, causing the entire room to shake.

"S-Steward Jin!" Wu Jie blurted this name out loud, feeling as though a mountain had been lifted from his chest.

"What?!" Patriarch Lin exclaimed.

"Who is this Steward Jin? I don't recognize this name." Lin Chunhua immediately asked for more information.

"Steward Jin is one of our most loyal servants. He's currently serving Lin Minghai, my son..." Patriarch Lin muttered in a low voice.

There was no way he could hide this information since everyone knew about it. If he tried to hide it from Lin Chunhua, it would immediately be exposed as a lie, and he would experience his father's wrath.

"Don't tell me your son..." Lin Chunhua's body trembled in anger.

"W-Wait! He only said Steward Jin's name! While it's true that he works directly for my son, there's no evidence that suggests my son is part of this farce! For all we know, Wu Jie could be lying about this whole thing!" Patriarch Lin exclaimed.

"Then why don't we speak with this Steward Jin and see for ourselves what he has to say about this situation?" Yuan suddenly said.

And he continued, "Also, he isn't lying."

Yuan suddenly pointed at the chains restricting Wu Jie.

He released some of his Sword Qi the following moment, cutting the chains apart.

"It would be in the Lin Family's best interest to compensate this man for his troubles."

Lin Chunhua nodded, "I will personally compensate him once all of this is over. You have my word."

"Then let's call for this Steward Jin, shall we?" Yuan smiled.

Patriarch Lin immediately summoned Steward Jin to their room.

Sometime later, a man with a naturally cunning face entered the room, his entire body already drenched in sweat.

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Chapter 1090 The Man Responsible(3)

"Greetings, Patriarch Lin—"

"Save your breath. You'll need it." Patriarch Lin interrupted with a cold expression on his face.

Steward Jin swallowed nervously before turning to look inside the room, and that was when he noticed an exhausted-looking man sitting in the middle of the room.

Steward Jin immediately recognized this man to be the one he forced to take the blame for the incident, and his body began squeezing out every ounce of sweat it contained once he realized the situation.

"What's wrong, Steward Jin? Do you recognize this servant?" Lin Chunhua pretended to be ignorant and asked.

"Y-Yes... He's one of many servants in the Lin Family..." Steward Jin responded in a shaky voice.

"Is that all? What else can you tell me about him?" Patriarch Lin continued to ask.

"I..."

However, Steward Jin couldn't utter another word out of his mouth.

"Let's stop this pointless chatter and get straight to the point. Wu Jie, is this man, Steward Jin, the individual who forced you to take the blame?" Lin Chunhua suddenly said.

Wu Jie glanced at Steward Jin, seemingly hesitant to respond.

"Don't forget, both you and your family have our full support." Patriarch Lin reminded him.

Wu Jie nodded, and after taking a deep breath, he spoke, "Yes, he is the man who threatened my family."

"THAT'S A LOAD OF BULLSHIT!" Steward Jin subconsciously roared out loud.

When he realized what he'd just done, he quickly followed it up, "Patriarch! Ancestor! That man is speaking nonsense! I never threatened him! I am being framed!"

And before they could respond, Steward Jin pointed at Wu Jie and continued, "You claim that I'd threatened your family, but what proof do you have to back that claim?! How dare you try and frame me! A mere servant!"

The room became dead silent.

A calm voice broke the silence a moment later, "There is only one proof we need."

"What?"

Steward Jin shifted his gaze to the handsome young man sitting on the other side of Wu Jie.

Yuan pointed at the Grail of Truth resting on the table and continued, "He's not lying, and that is all I need to know that you're guilty."

"Now tell me, are you solely responsible for this mess, or are there others?"

"..."

Steward Jin didn't dare to speak, as he didn't want to drag his master to hell with him.

However, Lin Chunhua wasn't having any of this, and he grabbed Steward Jin by the neck before lifting him into the air.

"SPEAK! WHO ELSE IS RESPONSIBLE?!"

"N-Nobody! I am the only one responsible!" He muttered.

The Grail of Truth immediately began pulsating with light.

When Lin Chunhua saw this, his expression turned cold, and he suddenly tossed Steward Jin across the room.

The room shook slightly when Steward Jin's body slammed into the wall, leaving behind a large crack on it.

Patriarch Lin approached Steward Jin and spoke in a low voice, "If you tell us the truth, I might spare you the death penalty."

Feeling as though a dim light had appeared in his seemingly pitch black situation, Steward Jin became hopeful that he might survive this ordeal.

"On the other hand, if you don't, I will personally torture you for a hundred years." Lin Chunhua suddenly said.

Steward Jin's body trembled in fear upon hearing such horrifying words, and he subconsciously muttered out loud, "M-Minghai! Young Master Lin Minghai is also responsible!"

The temperature in the room suddenly dropped significantly, and Patriarch Lin mumbled in a low voice, "Minghai...? He's also responsible for this?"

Patriarch Lin didn't want to believe that his son was involved with the Silent Rippers, but somewhere deep within him believed otherwise.

"Lin Minghai... Although I don't recognize this name, since he has the Lin Family's surname, is he a direct descendant?" Lin Chunhua asked his son, who nodded in a stiff manner.

"Yes... He's my son..."

"..."

After a moment of silence, Lin Chunhua spoke, "I don't care if he's your son or your wife. If he's responsible, he will take responsibility. Bring him here."

Patriarch Lin had no choice but to summon Lin Minghai to the room.

Several minutes later, Lin Minghai entered the room.

"Greetings—"

A clear sound rippled in the room almost immediately after Lin Minghai opened his mouth.

Lin Minghai looked at his father with a look of disbelief on his face after realizing that he'd just been slapped in the face.

"Father...?" Lin Minghai mumbled.

"Absolutely useless! You're a disgrace to the entire family!" Patriarch Lin uttered in a cold and disdainful voice.

It was at this moment Lin Minghai noticed the other figures in the room, and when he saw the expression on Steward Jin's face, he instantly realized his situation.

"W-Wait! I can explain!"

"So you're not even going to deny it?" Lin Chunhua said.

"I..." Lin Minghai was speechless. If Steward Jin had given him up, there was no way he could talk his way out of this. The only thing he could do is hope that they wouldn't kill him because of the Lin Family's blood that is currently running through his veins.

"This was all Steward Jin's idea. I merely followed it."

"No matter if you came up with the idea yourself or you're simply going along with it, you're just as guilty." Lin Chunhua sneered.

He turned to look at Patriarch Li and continued, "You have assured the Young Master that you will punish the culprit with death regardless of their identity, and your son is no exception. But since he is your son, I will allow you the courtesy to end his life."

"As for you..."

Lin Chunhua suddenly looked at Steward Jin.

Whoosh!

Before Steward Jin could even open his mouth, Lin Chunhua tossed his sword that was aimed directly at Steward Jin's heart, pinning him into the wall and killing him instantly.

Lin Minghai fell on his buttocks when he saw this, and he even pissed his own pants.

"P-Please have mercy, father!" Lin Minghai crawled to Patriarch Lin's feet and began begging for his life.

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Chapter 1091 Killing Lin Minghai

"You are pleading to the wrong person for mercy." Patriarch Lin kicked his feet, sending Lin Minghai flying.

Lin Minghai immediately stood back up and rushed to Tian Yanyu's side before kneeling before her with his face full of tears and snot.

"Please! Have mercy, Lady Tian! I was wrong! I promise that I will never bother you again if you spare my life!"

Tian Yanyu remained seated on the couch with a calm expression on her face as she silently watched Lin Minghai plead for his life with his knees kissing the floor.

This was a scene that she'd seen multiple times in her dreams, but she never imagined that it could become a reality.

However, as much as she wanted to kill him, she wasn't sure if that was a good decision, especially since the Lin Family could hold a grudge against her family for killing Lin Minghai.

She turned to look at her family for advice.

Unfortunately, both her parents were still frozen stiff from fear because of their situation.

Tian Yanyu proceeded to shift her attention to Yuan, who calmly smiled before speaking, "Just speak your heart's desire. No matter your decision, I will protect you and your family."

When she saw the calmness on Yuan's face, Tian Yanyu also calmed down.

"Okay." She nodded before turning to look at Lin Minghai, whose face was filled with tears and snot.

"You have been a thorn in my life for many years now, and I cannot count the amount of times that I wanted to kill you with my own hands. However, I lacked both the power and courage."

After taking a deep breath, she continued, "But things are different now."

A cold light flickered within her gaze, and she stood up before facing Lin Minghai.

"I wanted to kill you when you tried to bully me into submission. I wanted to kill you when you messed with my family. I have been wanting to pierce your neck with my sword for many years now, and now that I have the chance, it wouldn't make sense for me to refuse."

Tian Yanyu retrieved her sword from her spatial ring.

"Hiii!" Lin Minghai fell on his buttocks again, and he started kicking his feet at the floor, pushing himself away from Tian Yanyu.

"F-Father! Are you really going to let her kill me?! I am a descendant of the Lin Family! I am your son! You must save me!" Lin Minghai turned to look at Patriarch Lin for help, but his face froze when he saw that Patriarch Lin wasn't even looking at him.

In fact, Patriarch Lin appeared to be ignoring him on purpose.

Seeing this, Lin Minghai knew that his fate was sealed and that he was doomed.

"Please... Lady Tian... Spare my insignificant—"

Whoosh!

Tian Yanyu suddenly took a large step towards Lin Minghai while thrusting her sword at him.

Her cold blade penetrated his neck and came out the other end.

After skewering Lin Minghai's neck with her sword, Tian Yanyu flicked her arm, decapitating Lin Minghai completely with one swift and decisive movement.

Lin Minghai's headless body collapsed on the floor a moment later, and not wanting his blood to dirty the room, Lin Chunhua sealed the fatal injury.

Tian Suyin snapped out of her daze after hearing the sound of Lin Minghai's head fall to the ground.

"Yanyu... You..." She was in disbelief, and she feared the Lin Family's retribution.

The room fell silent once again.

Sometime later, Yuan stood up and said to the Lin Family, "Thank you for upholding your promise. I will consider this whole situation settled now, and I will not fault the Lin Family any more."

Lin Chunhua bowed to him, "We only did what was natural."

"Then we will be leaving now." Yuan proceeded to walk towards the door only to stop at the door.

He turned around and continued speaking, "Just a reminder, the Tian Family is under my protection. Any harm towards them and I will consider it a personal attack on me."

"Please be at ease, Young Master. The Lin Family will not touch the Tian Family. In fact, we will even compensate them for whatever damage we've caused them." Lin Chunhua said.

"I-It's okay. We appreciate the offer, but what's done is already done. Let's not dwell on the past and keep moving forward." Tian Xianzu said with a stiff smile on his face.

As enticing as Lin Chunhua's offer was, Tian Xianzu wanted to end all relationships with the Lin Family as soon as possible. And as long as nobody deliberately messes with their business, they will eventually recover all of their losses.

Yuan and the Tian Family left the Lin Family shortly after and returned to their own territory.

Lin Chunhua turned to look at Wu Jie and said, "You will also forget everything that transpired here today. I promise the Lin Family will not touch you or your family for as long as you keep your mouth shut."

"Yes! Please excuse me!" Wu Jie bowed to them before running out of the room.

"Tell the family and others that your son had died in an accident." Lin Chunhua said to Patriarch Lin once they were alone.

"I know," Patriarch Lin sighed.

"Let today be a lesson. This is what happens when one offends someone from the upper heavens. We're lucky to get away with just two dead bodies. If he wanted to, he could've eradicated our entire family."

"I know..." Patriarch Lin repeated in a spiritless voice.

"I will give you some time to rest. We'll talk again in a few days." Lin Chunhua disappeared from the room shortly after.

Later that night, while Lin Chunhua was in his room cultivating and trying to forget about the whole incident, he suddenly sensed a presence appeared in his room like a ghost, forcing him to stop his cultivation.

"Who's there?!" He shouted as he snapped his eyes open.

However, there was nobody else in the room.

'Am I being paranoid?' He wondered inwardly.

Lin Chunhua closed his eyes and resumed his cultivation shortly after, completely unaware of the figure— an old man standing behind him like a ghost.

'At last, I've finally found you, Master...' A profound smile appeared on the old man's face as he secretly consumed Lin Chunhua's memories, taking them for himself.

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Chapter 1092 Vanishing Demon

After leaving the Lin Family's residence, Yuan and the Tian Family went straight back to their own residence.

None of them spoke a word to each other during the whole journey back, and when they finally returned to their residence, the Tian Family could finally take a breather.

Tian Yanyu fell on her knees the moment they entered the residence, and she would stare at her hands that had been trembling nonstop since she killed Lin Minghai.

'I still cannot believe it... Did I really kill Lin Minghai with my own hands? Am I actually dreaming? If this is a dream, I do not wish to wake up from it...' She sighed inwardly.

Seeing Tian Yanyu on her knees, Yuan approached her and offered her a hand.

"Are you okay?" He asked.

Tian Yanyu lifted her head to look at him without moving the rest of her body, and she mumbled in a low voice, "Who are you, really...?"

Yuan chuckled, "You've asked me that same question so many times that I lost count now."

"Then allow me to ask you. Just who are you, really? And why are you helping us? I swear, if you give me that same bullshit—" Tian Suyin said.

"Does it really matter?" Tian Xianzu suddenly interrupted.

"Honestly, I don't care about his identity. The only thing that I know is that he'd helped us deal with the Lin Family, finally giving our Tian Family some peace."

"Peace?" Tian Suyin sneered, "Do you really believe the Lin Family will just sit back and act as though nothing had happened today? We killed one of their direct descendants! And it was even done inside their own home! It may not happen tomorrow or even a decade from now, but they will definitely settle this debt one day!"

"We will deal with it when that day actually comes. For now, let's just relax and take full advantage of this peace." Tian Xianzu said with a bittersweet smile on his face.

"I... I have to agree with Father, Mother." Tian Yanyu suddenly said.

"Lin Minghai would not have stopped until I was groveling at his feet, so our family would have to deal with the Lin Family regardless of what happened today. As for Xiao Yang's true identity... Despite my question just now, I don't really care about that anymore. While it's true that I am curious, I won't pursue it if he doesn't want to reveal it. As long as he isn't a threat to us, I couldn't care less about his identity."

Tian Yanyu stood back up and glared at Yuan with clear eyes.

"Thank you, Xiao Yang. Because of you, I was able to turn my dream into a reality and kill Lin Minghai. Now I won't have any more nightmares about him. If there's anything that I can do for you, don't hesitate to ask, as I am now indebted to you."

Yuan shook his head, "No, you don't owe me anything. In the first place, I helped you because of a debt my family owed your family."

"Then you can consider that debt fully repaid." Tian Yanyu smiled.

"Hmph." Tian Suyin snorted, "Now that you no longer owe our family any debt, you may leave."

"I-Ignore her! You can stay here for as long as you'd like, Xiao Yang!" Tian Yanyu quickly said.

"Thank you. Then if you don't mind, I would like to stay here for a little longer until I figure out my next steps."

"Didn't you say that you'd like to visit my sect— the Jade Sword Manor? We can do that next!" Tian Yanyu recalled.

"Alright, when do you plan on bringing me there?"

"We can go back as soon as tomorrow if you want."

"Sure." Yuan nodded.

That night, Yuan logged off to notify Meixiu and the others about his plans.

"How long do you plan on staying with this family?" Chu Liuxiang asked him.

"I'm not sure yet, but I will let you know the moment I do."

"Then I will continue cultivating at the Cultivators' Haven until you return. I've made significant progress in my cultivation, so much so that I was going to ask you to go on without me for a while longer."

"Me too." Meixiu said.

"That's perfectly fine. In fact, if you wish to continue cultivating in seclusion even after I am done with the Tian Family, just let me know. It will benefit you more than just following me around, after all."

"Then it's decided! Meixiu, let's have a race to see who has the most breakthroughs!"

Chu Liuxiang suddenly said.

"Sure...?" Meixiu mumbled with raised eyebrows.

Meanwhile, Lin Chunhua was losing his memories without even being aware of it.

'Master is currently being hunted...' The old man sighed inwardly when he realized the situation through Lin Chunhua's memories.

He wasn't worried about the Seven Legacy Families, but with people coming from the upper heavens was a different story.

'He won't be able to handle the upper heavens in his current state, but they also don't know the Master's identity in this life yet... I must keep it that way for as long as possible.'

'Looks like I will have to wait a little longer before I can see you again, Master...'

"How troublesome." The old man subconsciously sighed out loud.

"Who?!"

His subconscious sigh alerted and startled Lin Chunhua, who quickly attacked behind him without even looking.

The old man avoided the attack with ease before distancing himself from Lin Chunhua.

Lin Chunhua didn't immediately attack the old man again, mostly because he was feeling apprehensive about the whole situation.

This old man was able to enter his room and get behind him without alerting him until the accidental sigh, which is more than enough to tell Lin Chunhua that he was dealing with someone he couldn't fathom.

"You... Who are you?" He asked after swallowing nervously.

The old man smiled and said, "I have many names, but you may call me Vanishing Demon."

"Vanishing... Demon?" Lin Chunhua forcefully swallowed again.

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Chapter 1093 Vanishing Demon(2)

Lin Chunhua felt an intense sense of dread coarse through his body as he stood before the old man known as the Vanishing Demon. With hundreds of years of experience, he instinctively knew the old man was bad news.

Despite being one of the most powerful cultivators in the Third Heaven, he felt powerless, almost as though he'd gone back to the days when he was just a young and ignorant cultivator who'd just encountered a powerful beast that he had no hopes of defeating by himself.

"Vanishing... No, Senior Vanishing Demon, what business do you have with me?"

A slight smile appeared on Vanishing Demon's face, "You are a smart one, Lin Chunhua. Despite your status within this realm, you still remember how to be humble. People like you are rare in the upper heavens. If it weren't for this characteristic of yours, the Lin Family would have perished."

'He knows me?' Lin Chunhua doesn't recall introducing himself, and this was definitely their first meeting.

"Anyways, I am here to keep my Master safe." Vanishing Demon spoke.

"Your Master?" Lin Chunhua raised an eyebrow.

Who could possibly have someone this powerful under them in this small realm?

"Yes, and you've met him already. In fact, he was here just earlier today."

"Y-You mean that young man...?"

Yuan's image flashed inside Lin Chunhua's head.

Then he realized something, "W-Wait... To keep him safe? Why do you need to see me to do that? Are you worried that I might retaliate against him because of what happened today? I swear on my surname that I will not do such a thing!"

Vanishing Demon chuckled, "Retaliate? Even the Celestial Emperor couldn't defeat him, much less the Lin Family."

"The Celestial Emperor...? Just who are you guys...?" Lin Chunhua was speechless.

"Just a few ambitious individuals trying to do what they think is best for this world." Vanishing Demon smiled.

"Anyways, my business here is finished. You will be questioned about me in the near future, but don't worry, you won't remember a thing about our conversation just now, and it will be like our meeting had never even happened."

"What do you mean by—"

Before Lin Chunhua could even finish his sentence, Vanishing Demon disappeared from his room like a ghost.

He stood there with a dazed look on his face.

Several moments later, Lin Chunhua snapped out of his daze, and he proceeded to look around the room with a confused expression on his face.

'Why am I standing here? I was cultivating just a second ago...' He wondered inwardly.

He decided to not think too much about it and returned to his cultivation with all of his memories regarding Yuan erased from his memories.

However, he still remembered the Tian Family, as well as the incident with them, just not the person who was behind it.

After leaving Lin Chunhua's room, Vanishing Demon visited other people within the Lin Family, starting with Patriarch Lin.

Once he acquired Patriarch Lin's memories, he went on to steal the memories of everyone that knew about Yuan's existence, leaving no stones untouched.

Once he cleaned up the entire Lin Family, Vanishing Demon did not take a moment to rest and immediately went to his next target—the other Legacy Families.

After spending a few days combing through everyone in the Seven Legacy Families, Vanishing Demon went to his final destination, the Ji Family.

"Who are you?! How did you get in here?!" The 'Lord Ji' of this realm was greatly startled when Vanishing Demon suddenly appeared before him like a ghost.

"Don't mind me. I think I wandered in here by accident." Vanishing Demon said with a smile.

"Do you really expect me to believe such an excuse? Identify yourself!" Lord Ji shouted as he withdrew his weapon and pointed it at Vanishing Demon.

Vanishing Demon narrowed his eyes slightly and spoke in a calm yet cold voice, "A child such as yourself shouldn't play around with sharp objects. I advise you to put away that toy of yours before you get hurt."

"I will give you three seconds to identify yourself!" Lord Ji ignored Vanishing Demon's words and continued pointing his sword at him.

Vanishing Demon shook his head and sighed, "You people from the Ji Family are always the same."

A vicious light suddenly flickered within Vanishing Demon's eyes.

"Eh?"

Lord Ji turned to look at his right arm after he felt an odd sensation from it, and to his absolute horror, his entire arm had disappeared into thin air along with his weapon. However, he didn't utter a single cry and managed to endure the pain.

"I've never liked the Ji Family. A bunch of lap-dogs for the Celestial Emperor, yet you act as though you rule the Nine Heavens." Vanishing Demon sneered in a mocking tone.

"Fortunately for you, I am in a good mood since I have finally found my Master, so I am going to spare your life."

"You... Who are you?" Lord Ji asked with gritted teeth.

Vanishing Demon smiled and responded with a prideful aura around him, "Vanishing Demon."

Lord Ji frowned, "Vanishing Demon? Never heard of you. Why are you doing this? When did my Ji Family offend someone like you?"

"How about Evil God's Shadow Army? Have you heard of them?"

"WHAT?!"

A look of tremendous terror appeared on Lord Ji's face after hearing this name.

"Impossible! The Evil God's Shadow Army is just a legend— one that doesn't even exist in this world!"

"It doesn't matter if you believe it or not. After all, you won't remember anything after I am done with you."

"I won't remember anything...?" Lord Ji recalled a certain individual that was frequently mentioned when one spoke about the Evil God's Shadow Army.

According to the legend, the Evil God's Shadow Army, which was the Evil God's most powerful and secretive force, was managed by a nameless entity

that had the ability to steal one's memories.

"I see... So you're that nameless monster who can steal one's memories... However, that doesn't explain why you're here..."

Vanishing Demon smiled, "There is only one purpose for the Evil God's Shadow Army— to protect the Evil God, our Master. Now that you have this knowledge, my reason for being here should be obvious to you now."

"No way... The Evil God... He's back?" Lord Ji had a look of disbelief on his face.

"He has returned yet not at the same time. However, it will only be a matter of time before he officially returns, and when that happens, the Nine Heavens will be his to control."

Lord Ji was speechless.

"Anyways, I have said enough. Once I am finished here, I will finally reunite with the Evil God."

"Wai—"

Lord Ji opened his mouth, but he stopped speaking and moving and became dazed before he could even finish uttering his first word.

When he snapped out of it, all of his memories of Yuan and his conversation with Vanishing Demon no longer existed.

Naturally, this meant that he'd forgotten about Heaven's Judgment and that he was supposed to find and hunt Yuan.

In just a few days, Vanishing Demon had managed to erase Yuan's existence from the Third Heaven.

"Now that I've brought you some more time, it's about time we met, Master Tian..."

Vanishing Demon disappeared into the night after he was finished with the Ji Family.

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Chapter 1094 Jade Sword Manor

The day after the incident at the Lin Family, Yuan left the Tian Family with Tian Suyin and Tian Yanyu.

"Are you sure you want to stay behind? What if the Lin Family attacks while we are away?" Tian Suyin looked at her husband with a worried expression.

"Stop being so paranoid. I have a good feeling the Lin Family won't bother us." He nodded with a calm smile.

Sometime later, they left the residence and went to the nearest city teleporter.

"Before we arrive at the sect, I want you to remember some rules." Tian Suyin said to Yuan after they exited the teleporter and made their way to the Jade Sword Sect.

"One, you will not wander the sect alone. Two, you will have someone with you at all times."

She turned to look at Tian Yanyu and continued, "Since you agreed to let him in the sect, he'll be your responsibility. Don't let him out of your sight."

"I know..."

Yuan couldn't help but smile, "Why do you have to make it sound like I have some ulterior motive for visiting your sect?"

"You don't?"

"I don't."

"I don't believe you." Tian Suyin snorted.

Yuan casually shrugged.

Once they arrived at the sect, Tian Suyin said to Tian Yanyu, "Don't forget about the upcoming event. There will be a briefing about it tomorrow."

"I know."

Tian Suyin went ahead into the sect and quickly disappeared from their sights.

"Let's get you checked into the sect as a guest first." Tian Yanyu said to Yuan.

"Okay."

Yuan proceeded to follow her into the sect.

Sometime later, they stopped above a large building.

"This is our administration building. Once we check you in, you'll be given a guest uniform. You'll have to wear this uniform for as long as you are within the sect." Tian Yanyu explained to him as they descended in front of the building.

The moment they entered the building, Yuan could feel multiple pairs of eyes staring in their direction.

"Disciple Yanyu! You're back in the sect, and you're okay!" An old man with short white hair rushed over when he noticed them.

"Hello, Elder Meng. Of course I am fine. Why wouldn't I be?" Tian Yanyu showed him a friendly smile.

"Why wouldn't you be?" Elder Meng looked at her with wide eyes.

"There's a rumor going around that the Lin Family has captured you and is holding you prisoner! Did that not happen?"

"I wouldn't be here if I was captured, now would I? I don't know where that rumor came from, but it's not true."

"That's relieving to hear. Then the rumor about your family starting a fight with the Lin Family is also false, right?"

"That's... true. However, it's already been settled."

"That doesn't sound assuring. However, now that you're back in the sect, even the Lin Family cannot touch you. We've warned you multiple times to not leave the sect, but alas..." Elder Meng shook his head.

He then shifted his gaze to the handsome young man standing behind her.

"Who's this young man? Your boyfriend?"

Tian Yanyu chuckled, "This is Xiao Yang, a guest in my family, and he's also our savior. I brought him here because he wanted to look at our sect."

"Xiao Yang, this is Elder Meng. He's a close friend of my mother, and he used to be my tutor even before I came to the sect."

Tian Yanyu introduced them to each other.

'She didn't deny it...' Elder Meng could only think about how Tian Yanyu had ignored his earlier comment calling Yuan her boyfriend, something she would usually deny on the spot and even get angry about it.

'Just who is this Xiao Yang? How interesting...' He smiled inwardly.

"Anyways, can you help him with the procedures?" Tian Yanyu asked a moment later.

"Sure thing. Follow me, Xiao Yang."

Yuan followed Elder Meng to one of the tables, where he would give some information about himself to the sect.

'P-Peak Spirit King?!' Elder Meng's jaw dropped to the floor when he saw Yuan's cultivation on the paper.

He turned to look at Yuan, and sure enough, the aura of a Spirit King was emanating from Yuan's body, but he couldn't tell the exact level.

'He's not even 20 years old, and he's already a peak Spirit King? Where did such a monster come from, and how come I have never heard of him until today?' Elder Meng's trembling hands began sweating as he learned more about Yuan. He was beginning to understand why Tian Yanyu seemed to treat him differently.

Sometime later, Elder Meng returned to Yuan with his new uniform.

The majority of the uniform was black with a golden sword around his chest area.

"Here is your guest uniform. Please wear this for as long as you're within the sect. This way, we know that you're a guest. We have a changing room right over there." Elder Meng pointed to the door at the end of the room.

"I understand."

Yuan immediately went to change his clothes.

"You gave him the honorable guest uniform? Even though you know nothing about him?" Tian Yanyu asked Elder Meng when she saw the black uniform in Yuan's hands.

"Regardless of their identity, if they're a peak Spirit King, they deserve no less." Elder Meng said in a serious voice.

"By the way, where did you find a genius like him?"

Tian Yanyu smiled and spoke, "Believe it or not, he's the one who found me. He appeared out of the blue one day and has been helping me and my family since then— he's like a gift from the Heavens."

Elder Meng raised his eyebrows at such a suspicious situation.

"Are you sure you can trust him?"

"Besides my family, he's the only person I trust unconditionally. I know it might sound crazy, but I really cannot sense any malice from him. No matter his reason for helping my family, I am grateful for it."

Yuan came out of the changing room a few minutes later, and when Tian Yanyu saw his new look, her face turned slightly rosy. Naturally, she was unaware of this and only felt a little warmer than usual.

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Chapter 1095 Jade Sword Manor(2)

Elder Meng whistled after seeing Yuan in their guest uniform.

"Not bad, young man. But you would look even cooler in our official uniform. How about joining our sect? With your cultivation, you would immediately become a Core Disciple or even a high-ranking sect elder if you wish."

Yuan smiled at his offer and said, "Thank you for the offer, but I don't plan on staying in this world for too long."

"This world...? Are you going to challenge the Stairway to Heaven soon?"

"Something like that." He nodded.

"I see. What a pity."

"..." Tian Yanyu looked at Yuan with a perplexed expression on her face after hearing this.

'We've just met, yet he's already leaving...?' She sighed inwardly.

"Come on, I will show you around the sect." She said to him a moment later.

"Alright."

Yuan left the building with Tian Yanyu the next moment, and she would proceed to give him a tour around the Jade Sword Manor.

Unlike the sects within the Lower Heavens, the sects within the Third Heaven are so vast that flying is required if one wanted to travel around, as most sects are split into hundreds if not thousands of smaller platforms that usually floated above the ground to save space.

"This is one of our training grounds. Our Jade Sword Manor has a total of 20 training grounds. Half of them are available to the Outer Court and Inner Court disciples while the other half are for Core Disciples and Elders."

Their first stop was a training ground meant for Core Disciples.

Due to their naturally low numbers, the training ground appeared to be empty at first with only a few disciples training on it, but their sword techniques were so flashy and powerful that if there were more disciples training there, they could accidentally hurt each other.

Of course, there were defensive formations to lower the risk of disciples injuring each other, but incidents still happen from time to time.

After watching the disciples for a few moments, Tian Yanyu suddenly spoke, "Xiao Yang, want to spar with me for a bit?"

Yuan looked at her with raised eyebrows, questioning her intentions.

"Even though I have seen you fight from afar, I still cannot fully grasp your prowess. Perhaps if I exchanged swords with you personally, I might understand you a little better."

Yuan smiled and said, "Sure, but let's do it later. I want to see more of this sect for now."

"Okay." Tian Yanyu was in no rush to spar with him, so she didn't mind waiting a little.

They left the training grounds to look at the other places.

"This is one of our medicine gardens. We have around 100 of them. Unless you want to get attacked by the guards, don't get too close to it. Only those with official orders are allowed to step foot on these grounds. Of course,

these aren't our most valuable treasures. Those are hidden somewhere within the sect."

The medicine garden before them was filled with all sorts of plants that stretched to the horizons, and a few moments after their arrival, Yuan could sense someone watching them from afar.

They didn't linger and proceeded to the next area shortly after.

Over the several hours, Tian Yanyu would bring Yuan to many different spots within the Jade Sword Manor, but even after spending so many hours, they were not even halfway finished with the tour.

Seeing how it was starting to get dark, Tian Yanyu suggested they take a break and eat some food.

"Sounds great." Yuan nodded.

Sometime later, they arrived at the Comfort Peak, a place designated for disciples to relax.

"This is Comfort Peak, where disciples go to relax or have fun when they're feeling tired or simply need to release some stress. If you seek entertainment, you will find most of them here. The best restaurants in the sect could be found here. What do you feel like eating today?" Tian Yanyu asked him.

"I will let you decide. I'm not a picky eater and I enjoy almost everything."

"Alright. Then I will bring you to my favorite store."

As Tian Yanyu led Yuan through the Comfort Peak, the disciples around them would stop whatever they were doing to stare at them.

"I-Is that Senior apprentice-sister Tian Yanyu?"

"There's only one person in this sect with her beauty. It's definitely Fairy Tian."

"I thought she was being held captive by the Lin Family after starting a fight with them?"

"Who's that young man beside her? He's even wearing the honorary guest uniform."

"I cannot sense his cultivation. Is he a mortal?"

The disciples mistook Yuan as a mortal since they were too weak to sense his cultivation.

Eventually, they arrived at their destination.

"Jade Pavilion..." Yuan read the large sign above the restaurant's door in a mumbling voice.

When they entered, a handsome middle-aged man approached them, "Welcome back to the Jade Pavilion, Disciple Tian. We've missed your presence dearly."

"It's been a while, Li Ming."

As a regular of this restaurant, Tian Yanyu knew the names of every worker there, and this included even the janitors.

"Is my regular spot available?"

"Of course. It is always available for you, Disciple Tian."

"I will need another chair since I have a guest with me today."

"Very well. Please, follow me."

They followed Li Ming to a room on the highest floor.

The interior of the room was small and shaped like a rectangle, but it had more than enough room for two people. However, the best part of this room was not the interior but the view it provided, as the guests were able to see pretty much the entire place through the balcony.

Once they were seated, Li Ming handed them a menu and patiently waited for them to order.

Tian Yanyu ordered two dishes while Yuan ordered ten times that amount, which raised eyebrows, but Li Ming didn't say anything and left to prepare their order.

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Chapter 1096 Jade Sword Manor(3)

"What do you think of our sect?" Tian Yanyu asked him once they were alone again.

"I like the scenery. It's completely different from the ones in Lower Heaven." He said with a smile.

"Lower Heaven...? You've been there?" Tian Yanyu showed a clear sign of surprise on her face.

"Yes. I was even a disciple at this sect for a while."

"Then why don't you become a disciple here for a while as well?" Tian Yanyu suddenly asked.

"I'm not sure what I would do as a disciple here." He shook his head.

"Well, what did you do in your previous sect?"

"I become a disciple mostly for the experience. Though, I must admit that the experience I had was limited."

"I can't say for sure since I've never been to Lower Heaven, but I would imagine that things are vastly different up here. But what I know for sure is that you'll have more opportunities up here, since we have more resources in the upper heavens."

"..."

After pondering for a moment, Yuan spoke, "Give me some time to think about it."

He immediately didn't refuse her offer. It was true that he didn't truly experience much in the Dragon Essence Temple, and he was interested in what it was like to be a disciple in the Third Heaven.

Tian Yanyu's hands turned into fists underneath the table from trying to hold her excitement.

'He didn't refuse! There's still a chance!' She smiled inwardly.

Tian Yanyu continued to ask Yuan about his experience in the Lower Heaven until their food had arrived.

They would stop talking to focus on their food and enjoy the scenery at the same time. Even though it was nighttime, Comfort Peak was still as lively as ever. In fact, it seemed even busier compared to when they first arrived.

An hour later.

Tian Yanyu stared at Yuan with a baffled look on her face.

'We finished eating at the same time even though he had ten times the amount of food I ordered...' She swallowed nervously.

Tian Yanyu snapped out of her daze a moment later, and she spoke, "Do you wish to rest for the night, or do you want to continue the tour?"

"Are you tired? We can rest if you want."

"I am not tired at all. In fact, I probably won't be able to sleep for the next several days since I am still excited about what happened at the Lin Family."

Yuan smiled, "Then let's continue our tour."

"Okay."

Core Disciples like Tian Yanyu received special treatment, and one of her many privileges was free food, so they left the restaurant without needing to pay.

The two of them didn't immediately leave Comfort Peak and lingered around for many more hours.

"This is one of the most popular shops around here. You get to sip on spirit tea for free while relaxing on a Spirit Calming Formation. Want to try it?"

Tian Yanyu stopped in front of this large building that was crowded with people outside.

"Don't mind the queue. Core Disciples have their own rooms, so we can go straight inside if you wish."

"Sure." He nodded.

They entered the building a moment later and walked straight to the only empty reception desk there while every other desk was occupied with disciples.

"Welcome to the Jade Tea Shop, Disciple Tian." The worker there immediately greeted her.

"A room for two."

"Sure thing."

The worker handed her a small jade tablet a moment later without asking any questions.

After taking the tablet, she brought Yuan to one of the rooms on the top floor.

Upon using the jade tablet to open the room that had nothing but two chairs that looked like massage chairs, a table, and a wooden drawer, Tian Yanyu said, "Take a seat. And do you have any preference for your tea?"

"I don't."

"Alright."

She went to the drawer and picked out a bag of tea leaves before preparing it with the teapot on the table.

Meanwhile, Yuan sat in one of the chairs, and his body immediately sunk into it, almost as though it was made of water and he was being embraced by clouds at the same time.

Once the tea was prepared, Tian Yanyu poured two cups and handed one of them to Yuan.

"This tea is made from leaves produced by our own sect. It has a special property that makes you feel as though you're slowly ascending to heaven. After drinking it, lay down and close your eyes."

After drinking the cup of tea, Yuan laid back on the chair and closed his eyes.

He could immediately feel the effects of the tea, and sure enough, his body felt incredibly relaxed while his consciousness was slowly drifting away.

This tranquilizing effect lasted for about two hours before it dissipated.

"There are even stronger teas if you want something longer lasting." Tian Yanyu said to him.

"I'm satisfied with what I experienced." He smiled.

"Then let's continue looking around."

After wandering the Comfort Peak for many hours until they were satisfied, they returned to the training grounds.

By the time they arrived, it was almost noon.

"Please go easy on me." Tian Yanyu said to him as she retrieved her sword.

"And don't go easy on me. Come at me as though you're trying to kill me."
Yuan said with a confident smile on his face.

Knowing his prowess, Tian Yanyu did not hesitate to treat their spar as though it was a life or death match.

Once they were prepared, Tian Yanyu made the first move, using a movement technique to get behind Yuan while swinging her sword at his neck.

Woosh!

Her blade struck nothing but air after Yuan dodged it with his own movement technique.

The few disciples at the same training ground quickly took notice of their spar, and they all stopped their own training to spectate.

It looked like Tian Yanyu had the upper hand at first, but these disciples quickly realized that was not the case.

"T-This guy... Who is this guy she's sparring with?!"

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Chapter 1097 Nameless Emperor's Tomb

"Heavens! I have never seen Disciple Tian being pushed around like this before!"

"That guest... he's strong!"

The disciples were mesmerized by their fight, and some of them even imagined being in Tian Yanyu's shoes. However, none of them could even imagine defeating Yuan, who seemed invincible at the moment.

After twenty minutes of going back and forth, Yuan decided to end things with a sword technique.

[Vanishing Ghost's Soundless Blade!]

Yuan's sword disappeared for a split second, and Tian Yanyu suddenly sensed a wave of Sword Qi fly past her, narrowly missing her.

When she sensed Yuan's Sword Qi, her life flashed before her eyes for a second before she realized that she was still alive.

The disciples spectating the fight also felt as though their life was suddenly in peril when they felt the Sword Qi despite their distance with some of them even falling on their buttocks.

Tian Yanyu fell to her knees afterward, her body soaked in cold sweat.

'W-What was that just now?' She asked herself inwardly.

This was her first time experiencing an Ancient-rank sword technique, so her reaction was normal.

"Are you okay?" Yuan approached her after putting away his sword.

Tian Yanyu didn't immediately respond. Instead, she turned her head to look beside her, and to her horror, there was a deep cut in the floor that stretched for hundreds of meters, and the cut itself was many meters deep, almost as if it had been sliced by a massive sword the size of a building.

"L-Looks like I am still underestimating you..." She mumbled in a low voice after forcefully swallowing her saliva that was stuck in her throat.

If he'd used this kind of power while fighting the Silent Rippers, he would have erased the Tian Family's residence along with the assassins.

'Is this his true power... or is he hiding even more strength inside that body of his?' Tian Yanyu looked at Yuan with caution and excitement.

Unbeknownst to her, she was witnessing less than 10 percent of Yuan's true prowess.

"That was an amazing fight! Senior apprentice-sister Yanyu, introduce your friend to us!" The other disciples suddenly started rushing over.

Tian Yanyu greeted her fellow Core Disciples with a smile, "He's Xiao Yang, a friend that I'd met recently."

"Senior brother Xiao!" The disciples greeted him with respect.

"How old are you, Senior brother Xiao? You don't look any older than us."

"I'm nineteen years old."

"What?! You're actually that young?!"

"What is your cultivation?!"

"Are you from the Four Ancient Family?!"

The disciples bombarded him with questions.

"Hey! You're all getting too close! Stop bothering him and give him some room!" Seeing how the others were getting closer and closer to Yuan, Tian Yanyu quickly acted by pushing them away, acting like his bodyguard.

The disciples were surprised by Tian Yanyu's unnatural behavior, so they subconsciously stepped away from Yuan.

"Xiao Yang, let's go. There's a briefing that I must attend in a bit. We can continue our tour afterward." Tian Yanyu then said.

"Alright."

After saying his goodbyes to the other disciples, Yuan left the scene with Tian Yanyu.

"Is it just me or did Senior apprentice-sister Yanyu express jealousy just now?" One of the disciples there asked a moment later.

"You think so, too?"

"I'm not surprised, considering his talent and young age. In fact, I'm even more surprised that I have never heard of him until today."

The disciples didn't stay around for too long since they also needed to participate in the upcoming briefing.

"What kind of briefing are you going to attend? It seems important." Yuan asked Tian Yanyu as he followed her to another peak.

"It's definitely very important, as it affects not only our sect but all of the sects in the Third Heaven."

"Oh? Now I am really intrigued."

"Every seven years, all of the sects gather to explore the Nameless Emperor's Tomb. I'm sure you've heard of them before. They're basically

gravesites created by powerful experts before their death so that they can pass down their legacy to those that pass the trials."

"Nameless Emperor's Tomb..." Yuan mumbled in a low voice.

"This has been a tradition since ancient times, and even though we've been exploring it for countless years, there are still plenty of powerful treasures to be found inside. There have even been occasions where people from the upper heavens come down specifically to explore the tomb."

"Can anyone enter the Nameless Emperor's Tomb? Or do they have to belong to a sect?" Yuan asked.

"Anybody can enter the Nameless Emperor's Tomb. However, that isn't recommended, since you won't have any protection, meaning you'll have to fend for yourself if you're attacked, and this is true even if you have a big group with you. Of course, this also applies to those in a sect. If you think the cultivation world is cruel out here, just wait until you go inside. Everything inside could be an enemy."

"Are you thinking about going inside the Nameless Emperor's Tomb?" Tian Yanyu asked him at the end.

"I'm still thinking about it, but it does sound fun."

"If you decide to join, let me know. I can speak with my mother, who can probably get permission to let you wear our uniform while you're inside."

"Thank you." Yuan nodded.

Sometime later, they arrived in front of a building that looked like someone's residence.

"This is my living quarters. I'm going to wash myself before I go to the briefing. You can either stay here and wait for my return or come with me to the briefing. It's all up to you."

"I will come with you. I want to learn more about this Nameless Emperor's Tomb, after all."

"Alright, then I will see you in a bit." Tian Yanyu disappeared into the bathroom after they entered the building.

While Yuan waited for her to come back out, Feng Yuxiang's voice suddenly resounded, "Young Master! I didn't realize this at first since it's been hundreds of years, but do you remember when I said that I'd found the Empyrean Overlord inside a Legacy Tomb 500 years ago? That was the Nameless Emperor's Tomb!"

"What?!" Yuan exclaimed after hearing this shocking information.

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Chapter 1098 Nameless Emperor's Tomb(2)

"Are you sure about this, Feng Feng? Did you really find the Empyrean Overlord inside this Nameless Emperor's Tomb?" Yuan asked for confirmation.

"I am certain, Young Master. My memories are getting clearer and clearer. I remember entering the Nameless Emperor's Tomb 500 years ago shortly after I escaped to the Third Heaven. I lacked treasures that were not too powerful to sell in this realm at that time, so I decided to enter the tomb, and after a gruesome experience that totally took me by surprise, I'd acquired the Empyrean Overlord and other treasures." Feng Yuxiang recalled her experience, feeling a tingly sensation known as fear when she did.

"The Nameless Emperor's Tomb is an incredibly dangerous and unfathomable place that even a Divine Beast who came from the upper heavens such as myself struggled greatly inside. In fact, I even died a few times. If it were not for my immortal body, I would've perished inside that Legacy Tomb 500 years ago." Feng Yuxiang's soul shivered just thinking about the nightmare she'd experienced while inside the Nameless Emperor's Tomb.

However, a bright smile appeared on Yuan's face when he heard this. "I wasn't sure if I wanted to go, but I cannot ignore such an opportunity after hearing this! The Nameless Emperor's Tomb must have something to do with my previous lives! If I want to learn more about myself, I must go there!"

"If that's the case, you should prepare yourself, Young Master. Even with your talents, I dare say that you'll still have some trouble inside. Hell, even the strongest cultivators can die in the most unlikely places."

"I know. I'll be careful." Yuan said.

"The Nameless Emperor's Tomb, huh?" Yuan wondered how he was related to this Legacy Tomb and what he'll find inside.

If the Empyrean Overlord belonged to one of his past lives, there has to be a reason that it was inside the Nameless Emperor's Tomb. Hell, the creator of this Legacy Tomb could very well be one of his past lives.

Tian Yanyu came out of the bathroom about 20 minutes later with a fresh look and stronger fragrance, smelling like a flower that had recently bloomed.

"I'm ready to leave. How about you?" She asked him.

"Yes. Also, I have decided to explore the Nameless Emperor's Tomb." Yuan said.

"Great! I will speak with my mother after the briefing."

"It's fine. I can protect myself, and I won't be alone."

"Oh, right... I forgot about them..." Tian Yanyu mumbled.

"Anyways, we can talk about this later."

"Okay."

Sometime later, they stopped at the Grand Jade Peak, one of the largest peaks within the Jade Sword Manor. Though, the only time this place becomes active are during summonings that required a large portion of the sect to gather in one spot, and currently there are over 200,000 disciples gathered.

"Impressive." Yuan was impressed by the sight when he arrived.

"This is just 2/3 of all the disciples in the Jade Sword Manor, too." Tian Yanyu said.

"While we wait, do you have any questions about the Nameless Emperor's Tomb?"

"Yes, I—"

Yuan suddenly halted his sentence when something in the Grand Jade Peak caught his attention.

He pointed at the massive stone statue in the distance and asked in a dazed voice, "Who is that?"

Tian Yanyu immediately knew what he was talking about even without looking at the statue.

"He doesn't have a name because we don't know it, but we believe he's the Nameless Emperor." Tian Yanyu explained as she stared at the statue of a tall, masked figure.

"How did you figure that out?" Yuan continued to ask.

"Because you can find similar-looking statues inside the Nameless Emperor's Tomb."

"I see... but why put his statue in the sect? Is he related to this sect in some way?"

"No, not that I know of. According to our sect's history, the founder of the Jade Sword Manor was a mere rogue cultivator before creating this place. He explored the Nameless Emperor's Tomb with some success and found some sword techniques as well as treasures that allowed him to become a peak cultivator in the Third Heaven and create the Jade Sword Manor."

"And he put that statue there as a way to pay respects to the Nameless Emperor, huh?" Yuan mumbled.

"Pretty much." Tian Yanyu nodded.

"Yuan... That's the Lord..." Lan Yingying's voice resounded shortly after.

She immediately recognized the statue to be the same as the 'faceless statue' that she'd taken care of since she was a child inside the Mystic Realm, but she was too surprised to say anything at first.

"Yes... Looks like he's related to the Nameless Emperor's Tomb as well."

Sometime later, a large group of figures could be seen approaching the Grand Jade Peak.

The people from this group were all Sect Elders of the Sword Jade Manor, and they were all being led by an old man who was emanating a naturally sharp aura that made those around him feel as though they were constantly being threatened with a sword by their neck.

"Greetings, Sect Leader and Sect Elders!" The world seemed to have trembled for a moment when all of the disciples greeted at the same time.

"That old man with the large silver sword behind his back is Yu Jian, our Sect Leader." Tian Yanyu mumbled to Yuan.

Once they arrived before the disciples, Yu Jian descended until he was floating in front of the statue while the Sect Elders gathered around the disciples.

"It is that time again, my disciples. The Nameless Emperor's Tomb will open for the world in 7 days, and it will remain open for 6 months." Yu Jian's voice boomed in their ears despite how soft it sounded.

"If you wish to explore the Nameless Emperor's Tomb, you must enter in groups of 10, and your cultivation has to exceed 3rd level Spirit Lord. If you've never experienced the tomb before, know that even if you prepare for the worst, it won't be nearly enough to prepare you for the nightmares in that place!" Yu Jian spoke in a solemn voice, sounding as though he was speaking from experience.

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Chapter 1099 Nameless Emperor's Tomb(3)

"You will be tested beyond your limits inside the Nameless Emperor's Tomb. You will experience things that you wouldn't have even in your worst nightmares. There is an extremely high fatality rate inside where over half of those that enter never come back out. Even as a Peak Spirit King, I still have to tread the place with extreme care. If you are willing to go into purgatory and experience the worst of this world, then explore the Nameless Emperor's Tomb. If you cherish your life, avoid it at all cost." Yu Jian continued to speak in a solemn voice, his words sending chills down all of the disciples' spine.

Of course, he was not trying to scare the disciples on purpose. Every word that came out of his mouth was the truth and what he'd personally experienced, and he wanted them to know that the Nameless Emperor's Tomb wasn't a playground for the weak. Hell, even the strong are considered weak inside, so one could say the 'strong' doesn't exist when they are within the tomb.

After taking a breather, Yu Jian continued, "With that being said, if you decide to challenge the Nameless Emperor's Tomb despite the danger, you could be rewarded with unfathomably powerful treasures or techniques that far surpass what should be allowed in our realm, just like our founder, who became one of the strongest cultivators during his era because he took the risks and was rewarded for it."

The disciples swallowed nervously as they imagined the possibilities.

Just several treasures from the Nameless Emperor's Tomb made a rogue cultivator who used to be a nobody into a powerhouse and the founder of a

top 5 sect. And since nobody knows how deep the tomb goes since not a single soul has ever reached the end, the possibilities were literally endless.

What if there exists a treasure at the end of the tomb that allows one to literally rule the Nine Heavens? Such a thought would normally be considered as a delusion, but when it comes to the Nameless Emperor's Tomb, this delusion seemed more realistic.

"Now let's talk about the Nameless Emperor's Tomb itself. While nobody knows when it first appeared or when it was first discovered, we've been exploring it for at least a hundred thousand years now, but despite our efforts, we still don't know how much we've explored or how long it'll take before we learn its secrets."

"Unlike most Legacy Tombs, the Nameless Emperor's Tomb is like a different world itself that one can explore freely with the only restriction being their own strength. Although most of the treasures in the outer areas are long gone, there are still new secrets being uncovered every time we enter, and there are powerful techniques waiting for those who can comprehend them."

Yu Jian would continue to talk about the Nameless Emperor's Tomb for several more minutes before he dismissed the disciples.

"Those of you determined enough to risk your life for a better life, come here in seven days and I will bring you to hell. You are dismissed."

Many disciples stuck around to talk to their friends and fellow disciples even after being dismissed.

"What do you think? Are you having second thoughts about the tomb now?" Tian Yanyu asked Yuan in a teasing voice.

"Even if it's a 90 percent chance of dying, I will still be willing to go." Yuan smiled.

Tian Suyin showed up a moment later.

"Is he causing you any trouble?" She asked Tian Yanyu the moment she appeared.

"Of course not." Tian Yanyu shook her head with a bittersweet smile.

"Is that so? Anyways, do you plan on entering the tomb this year? If you are, I want you to come with me and your father."

"I do... but..." Tian Yanyu glanced at Yuan before continuing, "I was thinking about going with Xiao Yang..."

"What?" Tian Suyin frowned, and she shifted her focus to Yuan.

"You're also going to enter the tomb? Are you going by yourself? Stop dragging my daughter into trouble with you."

"M-Mother! What are you saying?! Have you forgotten about his strength? He's strong enough to defeat the Silent Rippers by himself! If there's only one person in this place that is qualified to protect me, it's him!"

"Actually, your mother is right, Miss Yanyu. I plan on going as deep as I can, and I am not confident in protecting myself, much less someone else."

Tian Yanyu showed clear disappointment on her face after hearing his words, but it was not like she didn't understand where he was coming from.

"Y-You're right. I'm sorry. It was incredibly selfish of me to force you to protect me when the Nameless Emperor's Tomb could threaten even a peak Spirit King's life. I guess I've been spoiled by you a little."

Yuan smiled and said, "I don't mind traveling with you at first, but we will have to separate once it becomes too dangerous."

"What do you think, mother? Can he come with us?" Tian Yanyu turned to look at her with pleading eyes.

"I'm not senseless enough to deny more helping hands, especially one as capable as his..." She said.

It was at this moment another voice resounded, "May I interrupt your conversation for a second?"

They turned to see Yu Jian standing right next to them.

"S-Sect Leader!" Tian Suyin was startled by his sudden appearance.

"Don't mind me. I only want to speak with this young man for a bit." Yu Jian spoke while his gaze stared at Yuan's handsome face.

"I'm Yu Jian, Sect Leader of the Jade Sword Manor."

'The Sect Leader is introducing himself first...?' Tian Suyin swallowed nervously when she saw this, as this meant that he respected Yuan enough to become humble.

"Nice to meet you, Senior Yu. I'm Xiao Yang, a wandering cultivator."

"Senior...? There's no need to be humble when we're both peak Spirit Kings. In fact, I might even be inferior to you when it comes to raw talent." Yu Jian shook his head.

He noticed Yuan's profound aura even before he arrived at the Grand Jade Peak, but he has been resisting his urges to speak with Yuan until now.

Chapter 1100 Nameless Emperor's Tomb(4)

"The Sect Master admitted being inferior to a junior before his own disciples?!" Tian Suyin cried inwardly when she saw this. She almost couldn't believe her ears.

"Even if we have similar cultivation levels, it won't change the fact that you're older than me. "Anyways, what business do you have with me?"

"I was just wondering why you're in my humble sect. A genius such as yourself usually doesn't show up unannounced."

"I just wanted to see what kind of sect my friend belonged to, that's all."

"I see..." Yu Jian's gaze landed on Tian Yanyu for a second. "I hope this humble place is to your liking. If you have any troubles or concerns, don't hesitate to speak with me."

"I cannot bother the Sect Leader over such minor issues." Yuan shook his head.

"Please, I insist." Yu Jian smiled.

And he continued, "I will stop bothering you now, young friend. If you encounter any problems, show them this medallion."

He proceeded to hand Yuan a jade medallion that had his name on it.

He turned to look at Tian Suyin next and said, "I'd like to speak with you whenever you're available."

"I-I'm free right now." She immediately responded with a nervous look on her face.

Yu Jian nodded, and he left the scene with Tian Suyin.

It was obvious why the Sect Leader wanted to speak with Tian Suyin. He wanted to inquire about Yuan's existence.

In his eyes, a genius like Yuan couldn't possibly have been born in their world, so it would only be logical to assume that he'd come from the upper heavens. In fact, he's already heard rumors about the Celestial Emperor sending down powerful experts for reasons that he has yet to learn.

"Looks like we won't need to ask my mother for the sect's protection..." Tian Yanyu mumbled in a dazed voice as she watched her mother leave with the Sect Leader.

"Anyways, what do you want to do now? We have a whole week to prepare for the Nameless Emperor's Tomb." She then asked.

"Is there a place where I can learn more about the tomb?"

She nodded, "Yes. We have a library full of information about the place. When do you want to go?"

"Let's go now."

"Alright. Follow me."

Tian Yanyu brought Yuan to the Jade Enlightenment Peak, where all sorts of information and techniques are stored. Naturally, this meant that guests weren't normally allowed inside even if they had a disciple with them.

However, Yuan had the Sect Leader's medallion, so Tian Yanyu took the chance and brought him there anyway.

After arriving at the Jade Enlightenment Peak, Tian Yanyu led Yuan to a tall pagoda that had 21 floors.

This building is usually empty, but with the Nameless Emperor's Tomb near, it was currently crowded with disciples.

"Everything inside this building is related to the Nameless Emperor's Tomb. You can find others' experience inside the tomb and already discovered treasures all within this place. I'm going to leave you alone to prepare myself. If you need anything, contact me through this."

Tian Yanyu handed Yuan her communication jade slip.

"If you encounter any trouble, just flash the Sect Leader's medallion. It should settle most issues right there and then. Please don't cause any trouble because I will be responsible for it as your guide."

"Thank you." Yuan smiled as he accepted the jade slip.

Tian Yanyu didn't linger for much longer and left shortly after.

Yuan approached the pagoda, but he was quickly stopped before he could even reach the staircase.

"Hey! You! Stop right there!" A middle-aged woman flew towards him from a distance.

Once she landed, she continued, "Even if you are an honorary guest, you are not allowed to be here!"

Yuan didn't say anything and flashed the jade medallion he'd received from their Sect Leader.

The woman's eyes widened with shock for a moment, and her mouth stuttered as she tried to find the proper words to utter.

After a moment of silence, she cleared her throat and handed him an accessory. "Hang this around your belt. If you lose it, more people will come to stop you. Now if you'll excuse me."

Not wanting to stay around any longer, the woman quickly fled the scene after giving Yuan the accessory.

Yuan continued to approach the steps leading to the pagoda afterward, and sure enough, people would continue to stare at him with some of them even starting to approach him, but when they saw the little accessory hanging on his belt, they stopped and turned around.

Once he was inside, Yuan immediately began sweeping through the scrolls and jade slips on the shelves. And over the next four days, he would not take a step outside of the pagoda, spending all of his time staring at words.

However, even if he was given a month, he wouldn't be able to read all of the information inside the pagoda, as it had been accumulated throughout tens of thousands of years.

'I have a good grasp of what to expect in the tomb, but I doubt it is enough to prepare me for what I plan on doing... I guess I can only hope for the best...'

Yuan eventually left the pagoda after spending five days inside.

He returned to Tian Yanyu's living quarters afterward.

"How was it? Did you find the information useful?" Tian Yanyu asked him as she invited him inside.

"Somewhat. I know what to expect in the beginning, but there is too little information about the deeper areas." He sighed.

"I'm not surprised. Most people that went too deep never returned, after all."

"How about your preparation? Do you feel prepared for the tomb?" Yuan then asked her.

"No matter how much one prepares, they won't be prepared enough for the tomb." She shook her head.

"Anyways, I'm going to spend what little time we have left to meditate and mentally prepare myself. What about you?" Tian Yanyu said.

"I will do the same."

"You can use the room next to mine."

"Okay."

Tian Yanyu returned to her room shortly after.

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Chapter 1101 Commander Of The Evil God's Shadow Army

"Feng Feng, can you tell me about your experience with the Nameless Emperor's Tomb? I'll assume that you'd advanced deeper than most people since you were able to acquire the Empyrean Overlord— unless this treasure isn't as valuable as I thought." Yuan asked her after entering his room.

"While I can't say that I have traveled further than anyone out there, I did go pretty deep before I found the Empyrean Overlord." Feng Yuxiang's voice resounded the following moment.

"As you know, the Nameless Emperor's Tomb opens for half a year after it opens. It took me almost that much time to acquire it."

"Half a year... What happens when the tomb closes?" Yuan asked.

"Everyone that is still inside will automatically get teleported outside, and then it will remain closed for 7 years before the cycle repeats itself."

"Honestly, the hardest part about the tomb aren't the challenges. It's the pressure that threatens to shatter your soul, and the deeper you go, the stronger the pressure."

"A pressure, huh? Sounds troublesome."

Feng Yuxiang would continue to talk about her experience in the tomb as well as the trials that she had to challenge.

"The Nameless Emperor's Tomb is very unique when it comes to trials because most Legacy Tombs will automatically challenge every individual

that enters it, but the Nameless Emperor's Tomb allows one to choose their trials, so one can spend the entire 6 months inside without doing any trials. However, this naturally means you won't receive any rewards. Furthermore, powerful beasts and even demons roam the lands there."

"Demons...?" Yuan raised an eyebrow.

"Don't worry, they're not real demons. Everything but the treasures within the tomb was created using spiritual energy. With that being said, the demons are as powerful as real demons, and they even have its regenerative ability."

Feng Yuxiang would spend almost the entire day recalling her experience within the tomb.

"And that's how I acquired the Empyrean Overlord."

Once Feng Yuxiang finished, Lan Yingying spoke, "The Nameless Emperor's Tomb sounds a little similar to the Mystic Realm."

"Considering that they're both related to the 'Lord', I'm not surprised." Yuan said.

"Lord... Now that's a persona I haven't heard in a while." A new voice that Yuan didn't recognize suddenly resounded in the room.

"Who's there?!" Yuan snapped his head like a turtle and turned to look at the window, where an old man that he didn't recognize was standing with a smile on his face.

'How long has he been standing there? I didn't sense his presence until he spoke! This person is an expert!' Yuan swallowed nervously. He could instinctively tell at glance that this old man was at a level that he couldn't even comprehend.

"Be careful, Brother Yuan! He's dangerous!" Xiao Hua jumped between him and the old man, even retrieving her weapon without hesitation.

Feng Yuxiang and Lan Yingying did the same even though their instincts told them to run.

The atmosphere in the room immediately turned cold, and it suddenly felt like they were in a life-or-death situation.

However, the old man appeared completely relaxed, almost as if he wasn't even part of it.

Yuan stood there in silence. Despite the tense atmosphere, he had this inexplicable feeling that the old man wasn't a real threat.

"Let me ask you again... Who are you?" Yuan asked him, breaking the silence.

The old man took a deep breath before speaking, "My apologies, I was so overwhelmed with emotions that I'd forgotten how to act and made things awkward."

He proceeded to move his body and bent his knees.

"Don't move!" Xiao Hua shouted at him.

However, the old man ignored her warning and continued to lower his body until his knee was kissing the floor.

"Dong Ye, commander of the Evil God's Shadow Army. This unworthy subordinate greets the Master."

"Evil God's Shadow Army...? Master?" Yuan muttered in a dazed voice, his eyes as wide as saucers.

"You may not remember now due to your recent reincarnation, but I am your faithful servant. I've been following you since you were the Evil God, and I have been there for all of your reincarnation since then. If you don't mind me asking, how much of your past lives do you remember?"

"..."

Yuan was speechless.

Dong Ye didn't rush things and patiently waited for Yuan to digest the situation.

"Xiao Hua, Feng Feng, Yingying, lower your weapons." Yuan spoke a long moment later.

The ladies reluctantly lowered their weapons, but they were still on high alert and full of suspicion towards Dong Ye.

"So you used to serve the Evil God, huh? If that's true, what was his name? And who was he before the Evil God? Do you have any proof that you served him?" Yuan suddenly asked Dong Ye multiple questions.

Without hesitation, Dong Ye responded in a clear voice, "Master used to be known as the God of War before receiving the title of Evil God, and his true name was Tian Xian. If you still doubt me, allow me to show you some of my memories with you."

"You can share memories?" Yuan raised an eyebrow.

"Indeed. Will you accept my memories?"

Yuan didn't immediately respond and began pondering.

"Brother Yuan, I don't think we can trust him. He's too suspicious." Xiao Hua said.

"His aura is also insanely murderous. I have never seen anything like that before— except when the Young Master gets angry. He's definitely killed a lot of people." Feng Yuxiang said.

Dong Ye smiled, "It is true that I have a lot of blood on my hands. I didn't become the commander of the strongest assassination squad in the Nine Heavens by being a saint."

Yuan took a deep breath and spoke, "It's okay, my instincts are telling me to trust him, so I will do so. If he wanted to harm us, he has more than enough

power to do so, and we wouldn't be able to do anything to stop him."

He glared at Dong Ye in the eyes and continued, "Show me."

"As you command, Master." Dong Ye eagerly nodded.

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Chapter 1102 Evil God's Loyal Servant

After receiving Yuan's permission, Dong Ye proceeded to tap his forehead, causing a glowing orb of blue light to emerge from his head.

He then offered it to Yuan by raising it above his head, treating it as though it was an offering to god.

"Master, here are my memories."

The glowing orb of light floated off Dong Ye's hands and into Yuan's forehead.

Yuan immediately closed his eyes and began digesting the memories.

Inside Dong Ye's memories that went back tens of millions of years, Yuan could see himself when he was living as Evil God Tian Xian, and he was currently standing in front of a massive jade tablet while Dong Ye was kneeling behind him.

"How are things going for the Shadow Army, Dong Ye?"

"Everything is going as planned, Master. Our members are rising at a respectful pace every day. It won't be long before we can be fully operational."

Suddenly, the scenery changed, and Yuan could see Dong Ye standing before another person.

This person was clearly another one of his incarnations, but he didn't recognize this incarnation.

"Master, I am Dong Ye, your loyal servant. You may not remember me, but I have been serving you since your second life as the Evil God."

This person, who was a tall and handsome young man, spoke in a calm voice, "I remember you, Dong Ye. Although I don't remember everything, I remember enough to understand the situation."

The scenery switched again.

This time, Yuan recognized this person. However, this person's face was covered by a bland-looking mask.

'He must be the Lord...' Yuan thought to himself.

"Master, I am—"

"Dong Ye, right? Took you long enough to find me this time." The Lord spoke in a calm voice.

"How much of your memories have you recovered, Master?"

The Lord turned to look at Dong Ye and spoke, "I remember everything. I was born in this life with all of my previous memories. This is unprecedented."

Dong Ye was pleasantly surprised to hear this.

Sometime later, Yuan opened his eyes and spoke, "Since you know so much about me, can you help me recall what I have yet to remember to speed up the process?"

Dong Ye shook his head with a bitter sweet smile, "Unfortunately, I cannot do that."

"You can't, or you won't?"

"Per the Master's own orders, I won't." Dong Ye said.

"My orders?" Yuan raised an eyebrow.

He nodded, "Master wanted to naturally recover his own memories, so you ordered me to not give too much information regarding your past even if you threatened me."

"..." Yuan sighed inwardly after hearing this. Why would he make things more difficult for himself? He also did the same with the Stairway to Heaven.

"Anyways, I believe you when you say that you are my servant. With that being said, what are your plans now? Did my previous incarnations give you some sort of mission?"

Dong Ye nodded, "This body only has one purpose—to serve you until its death. If you need anything, I will be here for you."

Feng Yuxiang couldn't help but feel as though her role as Yuan's handyman was suddenly in jeopardy.

Dong Ye then continued, "However, with that being said, it's not as though I can constantly remain by your side. Master, are you aware of our current situation with the upper heavens?"

"No, what kind of situation are we in?" Yuan shook his head.

"The Celestial Emperor, our natural enemy, will be sending experts to the lower heavens to kill you. They will arrive in less than a month."

Yuan was left speechless after hearing this information.

"What?! Why would the Celestial Emperor do such a thing?! I've never even met the man!" He exclaimed.

"According to what I've learned from the Seven Legacy Families' memories, the Celestial Emperor is not specifically targeting you because of your identity. He doesn't even know your real identity, but because of the Heavens' Judgment, you now have a target on your back." Dong Ye explained.

And he continued, "Honestly, if the Celestial Emperor knew your real identity, I wouldn't be surprised if he personally came down here with his entire army just to kill you."

"How troublesome... And here I was planning on going to the Nameless Emperor's Tomb." Yuan gritted his teeth.

"Worry not, Master. This is why I am here. I have already erased the Seven Legacy Families' memories of you, so they won't be able to help those from the upper heavens to identify you. Furthermore, I will do my best to mess with those from the upper heavens and keep them from finding you. If you are ever in a dangerous situation that you cannot solve, break this jade slip and I will immediately come to you no matter what kind of situation I am in, even if I have to crawl through broken glass and the scorching ground. If you need me for anything else, use this communication jade slip to contact me."

Dong Ye handed Yuan two different jade slips.

"I would give you life-saving treasures and other useful treasures, but I cannot give you any significant assistance that could greatly affect your natural growth."

"Let me guess... I told you that." Yuan said in a sighing voice.

Dong Ye smiled and said, "The point of reincarnating multiple times is to expand your experience and talent. If you're given a silver spoon every time you reincarnate, it would defeat its purpose, after all."

"I understand the reasoning behind this logic, and I even agree with it. However, it still sucks." Yuan said with a bittersweet smile.

"Anyways, before I ask you more questions, let's introduce ourselves properly."

"In this life, I am Yuan. It feels a little weird to be called Master by someone as ancient as you, so you can just call me Yuan or Young Master like Feng Feng here. Feng Feng, introduce yourself." Yuan looked at her,

who silently nodded and proceeded to introduce herself despite being reluctant to do so.

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Chapter 1103 Controlling Fate

"Feng Yuxiang. I am a Divine Beast that carries the bloodline of a phoenix." Feng Yuxiang gave a brief introduction about herself.

"The rest of you should introduce yourself as well." Yuan looked at the others.

"Lan Yingying. I am a Divine Beast as well— a Divine Serpent."

Dong Ye, who already knew that Feng Yuxiang and Lan Yingying were Divine Beasts, nodded his head. While they can hide their identity from cultivators around their level, Dong Ye was an Immortal who has existed for millions of years. It was simply impossible to fool someone like him.

"A Phoenix and a Serpent, huh? It sure brings back memories." Dong Ye couldn't help but break out a smile on his face when he recalled the Immortal Monarch and his Divine Beast followers.

"The Immortal Monarch?" Yuan asked out of curiosity.

He nodded, "Do you remember?"

"No, but I am aware of his existence."

"His Divine Beasts were always fighting with each other over his attention." Dong Ye chuckled, "It caused the Mast— Young Master plenty of headaches. However, they were all reliable and loyal, which sort of balances things out."

Yuan suddenly remembered something and said, "Speaking of the Immortal Monarch... Do you know how to upgrade his bloodline? What about the Heaven Refining Physique?"

"The answers you seek are within the Nameless Emperor's Tomb."

"The Name Emperor's Tomb... Did I build it?" Yuan then asked.

Dong Ye smiled and said, "You will find out once you go inside."

Seeing how Dong Ye won't give him any direct answers, Yuan decided to give up and to wait to enter the Name Emperor's Tomb.

Dong Ye suddenly shifted his gaze to Xiao Hua, whose tiny body instinctively trembled.

"An exile, huh? The Young Master called you Xiao Hua, so you must be from the Asura Family. Do you believe in fate?" He asked while staring at her intensively.

Xiao Hua silently nodded.

"Then do you believe someone— a mere human can control fate?"

Xiao Hua raised an eyebrow and said, "Nobody can control fate."

"What if someone has such ability?"

"That's impossible. No human can have such an ability."

Dong Ye smiled and shifted his gaze back to Yuan.

"Believe it or not, someone out there has the ability to control fate, and he's standing in this room as we speak."

Xiao Hua and the others turned to look at Yuan, who was quite confused.

"You may not realize it, but you're subconsciously controlling fate."

"The Young Master is subconsciously controlling fate? How does that even work?" Feng Yuxiang asked.

Dong Ye shrugged, "Even I do not know the answer to this question."

"This is partially why the Young Master ordered me to not assist him too much, as it could affect his fate."

Yuan looked at his own hands.

'I'm controlling fate? Am I really doing such a thing?' He couldn't believe it.

Manipulating fate sounded very complicated, so it seemed very unlikely for him to subconsciously control it.

"What do you know about Xiao Hua's family?" Xiao Hua suddenly asked Dong Ye.

"I know a lot about the Asura Family. And believe it or not, but I also know a lot about you, Xiao Hua."

Xiao Hua frowned. "How? Xiao Hua was born in the Primordial Realm. Nobody can enter or leave this place without the Celestial Emperor's approval or the Ancient Seals."

"Sorry, but I cannot tell you." Dong Ye shook his head.

"Why not?"

"Because you're directly related to the Young Master, which means I will spoil him if I answer your question."

"Brother Yuan...?" Xiao Hua turned to look at Yuan with a look of wonder in her eyes.

"Anyways, if you have any more questions that aren't related to the Young Master's past, feel free to ask me. If you have any requests, I am also willing to hear it."

Yuan pondered for a moment before speaking, "The Nameless Emperor's Tomb will open very soon. Do you plan on going inside with us?"

"No, I will be staying out here to mess with the Celestial Emperor's lackeys and throw them off your track."

Yuan nodded, and he said, "Then if you don't mind, can you watch over my friends while I am inside the Nameless Emperor's Tomb? I don't know how long I will be staying inside, nor can I bring them to such a dangerous place with me. They're extremely valuable to me. I want you to protect them as though they're me."

Dong Ye nodded, "No matter who you want me to protect, I will protect them with my life."

Yuan proceeded to tell Dong Ye about Meixiu and the others who were training at the Cultivators' Haven.

"They are likely to spend all of their time cultivating inside the Cultivators' Haven, but better safe than sorry."

"Rest assured, Young Master. As long as I am breathing, no harm will come to your friends. Even if I am not constantly by their side, I can cover this entire world with my divine sense, so I will know immediately the moment they're in any danger no matter where I am."

"Covering this entire world with your divine sense? I have been wondering about this for a while now, but what is your cultivation?" Yuan asked out of curiosity.

"This humble one is only at the 7th level of God Ascension realm."

"God Ascension...?" Yuan mumbled in a dazed voice.

"If one's ascension towards Godhood succeeds, they will become a Cultivation God, which has been the peak of the Cultivation World since ancient times."

"You're not that far away from the peak of cultivation, yet you sound disappointed." Yuan couldn't understand this part.

"Because I know my limits, Young Master. As much as I hate to admit it, I don't have enough talent to become a Cultivation God. That is a truth that I must accept. You, on the other hand, have not only succeeded in becoming

a Cultivation God multiple times in your past lives, I have a good feeling that you'll break through that limit and achieve something unprecedented in our world." Dong Ye spoke as he gazed upon Yuan with a confident glint in his eyes.

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Chapter 1104 Arrival From The Upper Heaven

"Wait a second. I thought all cultivators in the Nine Heaven must abide by the rules of each heaven." Feng Yuxiang suddenly spoke.

"For example, the limit of cultivation in this world is the peak Spirit King. If someone who doesn't belong in this world appears, they would invoke Heavenly Tribulation. Will you be fine down here with your cultivation?"

Dong Ye nodded, "Only mortals abide by that rule. Immortals like me can ignore such a rule and come down here whenever we want. Even if we invoke a Heavenly Tribulation, it won't be strong enough to harm us. Though, it's a pain in the ass to come down here because we have to enter through the long route, so most of us won't bother unless absolutely necessary."

"Also, I am currently masking my presence, so the heavens don't even know I am here, and as long as I don't do anything crazy, it will remain that way. I am more worried about the Celestial Emperor than any Heavenly Tribulation because the Young Master won't be able to fight them at his current state."

"What's the situation with me and the Celestial—" Yuan halted his sentence midway.

"Never mind. I hope the Nameless Emperor's Tomb will have all of the answers."

Sometime later, Dong Ye's eyebrows suddenly twitched, and he spoke with a dejected face, "It's truly regrettable that I can only spend such a short time

with you after spending so much time apart, but I must leave now, Young Master. Some people from the upper heavens have just arrived in this world, and to minimize the chances of your true identity being known, I must disappear. However, even though I won't be by your side, I will always be watching over you. If you are ever in deep trouble, you know how to contact me."

"But before I go, I must apologize to you, Young Master. There is so much that I want to say to you— to tell you, but I truly don't dare to mess with your fate."

Yuan shook his head, "Don't worry about it. I understand your feelings, and to be honest, I like it this way even if it's a little more inconvenient for me. My past, my purpose, and my goals... I will unveil them as I follow my own path."

After giving Yuan a slight nod, Dong Ye dissipated into thin air like smoke.

"An Immortal who has reached near the peak of cultivation... Who could've imagined that such a powerful individual would be willing to serve someone." Yuan mumbled out loud after Dong Ye disappeared.

"That's just how amazing your existence is, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang chuckled.

"Don't flatter me." He shook his head.

Meanwhile, somewhere within the Third Heaven, a large hole appeared in the sky moments before a group of individuals came out of it.

There were 21 people in this group, and all of them had the cultivation of a peak Spirit King, but the aura they emitted far surpassed what someone at their cultivation base could ever achieve.

"Fuck, the spiritual energy in this place is so trash. It feels like I am breathing in dust with every single breath." One of them immediately complained after taking his first breath.

"How do people live in such an environment?"

"Let's hurry and kill that criminal and get the hell out of here as soon as possible."

Most of these people agreed with the sentiment. However, one couldn't completely blame them for their behavior. The spiritual energy in the upper heavens was countless times purer than the ones down here, and as cultivators, they have reached the level where they don't need to breathe in air to live, just spiritual energy.

These people have lived their entire life thinking that their spiritual energy was the standard, so it wouldn't be weird for them to have such a strong reaction after suddenly being exposed to something much worse.

"Anyways, where are the Ji Family and the Seven Legacy Families? I was told that they'd be greeting us the moment we arrived."

"Perhaps they got the location wrong."

"I wouldn't be surprised if a world of this low standard housed such dumb people."

Unbeknownst to these people, the Seven Legacy Families and the Ji Family all had their memories stolen by Dong Ye, hence why nobody showed up to greet them.

After waiting around for a few moments, these people split up to look for the Seven Legacies Families themselves.

When they found the Seven Legacy Families, these people from the upper heavens immediately demanded for answers. However, they quickly realized that nobody from the Seven Legacy Families knew about their arrival.

This made them wonder if the people from the upper heavens had forgotten to notify the Seven Legacy Families.

But they soon realized the truth—that the Seven Legacy Families and the Ji Family had their memories erased for some reason.

"What's going on? Who would erase their memories?"

"I think a better question would be 'who could have the capability to do such a thing in this world'."

"I only know of one person in the Nine Heavens who could erase memories, but that person's been missing for hundreds of thousands of years."

"I also don't think it's him. Why would he be down here stealing memories from mortals, right?"

The people from the upper heavens quickly dismissed the phenomenon, mostly because they couldn't be bothered to investigate any further.

But then they realized another problem.

Without the Seven Legacy Families' help, how will they ever find the person they were looking for? Even finding a needle in a haystack would be easier than this task since they at least knew what a needle looked like. However, it was not as though they could leave without even trying.

In the end, these people decided to stay around for a little longer to wait for the others that have yet to arrive.

These 21 people were just the first batch of people amongst a dozen, after all.

"In the meantime, I am going to take a look around. As shitty as this place is, it's a rare chance to experience the lower heavens."

"Try not to get yourself killed. You'd immediately become a laughingstock if you died in a place like this."

"Hmph. Even if my cultivation is suppressed to being a mere Spirit King, what could possibly hurt me down here?" This individual sneered in a mocking manner before disappearing into the world.

Many people from the group followed suit, as they were also curious about the Third Heaven.

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Chapter 1105 Nameless Emperor's Tomb's opening

The day before the Nameless Emperor's Tomb's opening, Yuan received a message through one of his communication jade slips.

"Yuan, Lady Xu will return in 5 days to give you what she promised."
Senior Bai's voice resounded inside his head.

'Oh... I was so occupied with the Nameless Emperor's Tomb that I nearly forgot about our agreement.' Yuan felt a drop of cold sweat appearing on his forehead. He couldn't imagine what he'd do if he didn't show up for the soul technique and Xu Jiaqi decided to not give it to him anymore.

'However, the Nameless Emperor's Tomb will be opening tomorrow, and I promised Tian Yanyu that I'd enter with her...'

As much as he wanted to enter the tomb with Tian Yanyu, he had to prioritize the soul technique, as it could potentially be the difference of whether he'll clear the Nameless Emperor's Tomb or not.

After preparing himself for Tian Yanyu's complaints, Yuan went to knock on her room.

Tian Yanyu opened the door a moment later.

"Hey."

"Hey..."

"Something wrong?" Tian Yanyu raised an eyebrow.

"You see, I just remembered that I had an appointment with someone, and this is an important meeting that I cannot miss, but it will happen five days after the Nameless Emperor's Tomb's opening, so I won't be able to enter with you on day one."

"What?! You're telling me this the day before it opens?!"

Tian Yanyu was clearly unhappy about the situation. However, even though her voice was loud, she didn't look angry.

"I'm truly sorry." Yuan lowered his head in an apologetic manner.

Tian Yanyu rubbed her eyes and sighed, "Don't worry about it. It's only five days, right? I can ask my mother to delay our entrance for you."

Yuan quickly lifted his head and said, "Please don't. Your mother won't like it and will probably refuse. Furthermore, you're not going with just your mother, right? We cannot delay the others just for me."

"Where will you guys be headed first? I will meet up with you in five days." Yuan suddenly suggested.

"We'll be spending our first month at the Nameless Stone Warrior. You know where it is, right?"

He nodded, "I memorized the map."

"Good."

The following day, Yuan and Tian Yanyu went to meet up with Tian Suyin, who brought them to the gathering area, where tens of thousands of disciples were waiting in anticipation with more to show up.

"Senior, due to another appointment I had arranged before coming here, I will be entering the Nameless Emperor's Tomb a few days after it opens." Yuan said to her, who merely shrugged.

"Why are you telling me? I don't really care if you come with us or not." Tian Suyin said.

However, while she claimed to not care, she wasn't telling the truth entirely. Since she knew how powerful Yuan was, she would feel less nervous inside the tomb, but that's no longer the case.

Tian Yanyu then spoke, "By the way, you can enter and leave the Nameless Emperor's Tomb as many times as you please, so you don't need to worry about that."

Sometime later, Sect Leader Yu Jian showed up at the gathering place and swept the crowd with a sharp and profound gaze.

'About 90,000 disciples...'

90,000 disciples was about a third of the Jade Sword Manor's entire disciple population, but compared to the other sects that will be bringing half of their sect, it wasn't anything impressive.

Once Yu Jian gave the disciples a short speech, he retrieved a spiritual treasure and mass teleported everyone there to another gathering area, one that was much closer to the Nameless Emperor's Tomb.

"The Nameless Emperor's Tomb is 100 km to the north. All of the major sects will have a spot reserved for them. Look for the flag with our sect's emblem."

After saying these words, Yu Jian went ahead and flew away.

The disciples there quickly followed suit.

Sometime later, Yuan and the disciples arrived at a vast and spacious land that had nothing in sight besides the very obvious and large temple that was situated right in the center of this area.

This temple was massive—larger than any building Yuan has seen before, and this included the buildings in the Giant's Continent.

The temple itself seemed to be made of white marble, and it appeared to be in pristine condition at glance, almost as though it was just created yesterday even though it stood for millions of years already.

When Yuan saw this temple, he could feel his heartbeats quickening, and he suddenly had this near uncontrollable urge to approach the place, like it was calling for him.

Surrounding the temple was a sea of people— tens of millions of people.

This reminded Yuan of the Mystic Realm, but the scale of this event was multitudes larger.

Still wearing the Jade Sword Manor's guest uniform, Yuan followed Tian Yanyu and the other disciples to their sect's assigned location in front of the temple, where Sect Leader Yu Jian was waiting.

"This isn't even half of the people participating." Tian Yanyu suddenly said to him.

"Since there are too many people that want to enter the Nameless Emperor's Tomb, all of the sects are given a set date to enter. The top sects will get to enter on day 1 while the weaker sects and rouge cultivators will enter a few days later. Although entering a few days late may not seem like much at first, these few days could be the difference between gaining enlightenment and gaining nothing. There have been plenty of cases where people were kicked out right before they could be enlightened."

"Is that so... When does the tomb open, anyway?" Yuan asked.

"It should open within the hour."

"I will stay here until you enter the tomb."

"Alright."

Thus, they began to wait for the Nameless Emperor's Tomb to open.

Meanwhile, more and more people showed up for the tomb's opening, including those that had no intention of participating.

Chapter 1106 Nameless Emperor's Tomb's Opening(2)

An hour passed within the blink of an eye while Yuan inspected the Nameless Emperor's Tomb with his divine sense.

Besides its pristine condition, there really wasn't anything too special about the temple itself— at least Yuan didn't notice anything unique about it.

He also noticed that even though tens of millions of people had gathered in front of the temple, they all left an empty path straight down the center leading to the temple for some reason, almost as though they were expecting someone to walk through the path.

About five minutes before the Nameless Emperor's Tomb's opening, the Ji Family showed up at the site.

All of the Sect Leaders and Clan Leaders went to greet the Ji Family upon their arrival, including Yu Jian from the Jade Sword Manor.

However, these powerhouses were absolutely gobsmacked when they noticed Lord Ji's unusual and shocking condition.

"L-Lord Ji! What happened to your arm?!"

Lord Ji, who was almost an invincible existence within the Third Heaven had suddenly lost an arm, an injury that most would consider to be crippling. However, who or what could possibly injure the strongest cultivator in the Third Heaven to such a degree? None of these Sect Leaders or Clan Leaders could imagine.

Lord Ji's body shuddered after being reminded of his injury— one that he doesn't even remember getting.

"I... I don't remember." He eventually shook his head. "When I woke up, my arm had disappeared."

The Sect Leaders exchanged glances with each other. What could have possibly caused such a phenomenon? One doesn't simply wake up with an arm missing!

These experts all believed that Lord Ji had been attacked while he was asleep, as that was the only logical explanation, but such a thing was easier said than done.

However, Lord Ji insisted that he doesn't remember anything, so the Sect Leaders and Clan Leaders had no choice but to drop the topic.

"I would normally give a speech, but as you can see, I am not in the condition to do so." Lord Ji spoke a moment later, and nobody there could blame him.

Eventually, it was time for the Nameless Emperor's Tomb's opening.

Yuan could sense a sudden change in the atmosphere, almost as though the presence of an otherworldly expert just showed up.

The temple suddenly began emanating a golden glow that would grow brighter with every passing second.

BOOM!

The entire Third Heaven shook for a brief second when a powerful ripple swept the place.

Suddenly, like a ghost, the figure of a tall individual wearing exquisite white robes appeared in the empty path that all of the sects had purposefully avoided.

This figure was entirely made out of spiritual energy, yet it felt like he truly existed as a real person, and he was carrying a large sword on his back while wearing a mask on his face.

When the experts there saw this masked figure, they all lowered their heads and silently bowed to him, their hearts trembling with reverence.

Although nobody there knew this masked figure's true identity, they all had a good feeling that he was the Nameless Emperor—the master of this unfathomable tomb.

Yuan's body trembled slightly when he saw this masked figure and the sword on his back.

'Empyrean Overlord...' It only took a glance for him to recognize the sword and the masked figure.

A few moments after he appeared, the masked figure began taking small strides towards the temple in the distance.

As he slowly approached the tomb, not a single soul in that area dared to make even the slightest movements, and even the most powerful cultivator in this world, Lord Ji, had to hold his breath.

Unbeknownst to most of the people there, several experts from the upper heaven were hidden amongst them, and they were just as awed by this masked figure's unfathomable presence despite being part of powerful families and sects in the upper heavens themselves.

'I have heard countless rumors about the Nameless Emperor's Tomb and its unknown master, but I never really understood why even the experts in the Ninth Heaven are wary of this place until today! This masked figure... If he is still alive today, he would, without doubt, be one of the strongest cultivators in the Nine Heavens!'

'How is he exuding such a powerful aura even though he's just a phantom created entirely out of spiritual energy?! Even the top experts in my family cannot emit such an aura while they are alive! This doesn't make any sense!'

After taking exactly 99 steps, the masked figure stopped his movements and proceeded to reach behind him to grab the Empyrean Overlord.

The moment his grasp tightened on the Empyrean Overlord, all of the experts there suddenly felt a cold sensation around their neck, almost as though there was a real blade pressing against their skin at this moment.

The experts tried their damned hardest to not swallow by accident, and their back was quickly soaked in cold sweat.

The experts from the upper heavens even subconsciously grabbed their weapons when they sensed this chilling sensation, but they quickly released their hands when they realized the situation.

'His Sword Qi is so profound that our body— our very soul— had instinctively reacted defensively even though it wasn't directed at us... Even the current Sword Emperor would look like a sword apprentice compared to him! Why does such an existence exist in this world?! What is the Heavens thinking, allowing such a thing to happen?!

While the experts from the upper heaven were in deep thoughts, the masked man suddenly made his movement and swung his sword vertically at the temple.

A beautiful arc of sword light was created by the swing, and it flew straight at the temple.

Sha!

Almost as though the sword light ripped through space itself, a massive portal suddenly appeared in front of the temple.

The Nameless Emperor's Tomb was finally open, but nobody there dared to move, as the masked figure had yet to disappear.

Thus, the tens of millions of people there patiently waited for the masked man to disappear after opening the tomb like he usually does. However, what happened next shocked everyone there.

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Chapter 1107 Nameless Emperor's Tomb's Opening(3)

'What's going on? Why isn't he disappearing like he normally does after opening the tomb?' Lord Ji and all of the experts there wondered inwardly when the masked figure continued to stand in front of the temple even many moments after opening the tomb.

Everyone there was puzzled by the situation, but none of them dared to approach the tomb until the masked figure completely disappeared even if they had to wait hours.

Moments quickly turned into minutes. The atmosphere there had become almost suffocating with everyone nervous about this phenomenon.

The Nameless Emperor's Tomb has existed for millions of years with many experts there experiencing the tomb's opening over a dozen times, yet nobody there had seen or heard about this kind of situation.

Did the Nameless Emperor's Tomb have a sudden malfunction? Was there something different about this year's event? Nobody there could say for sure, nor were they willing to find out, as even the slightest mistake could cost them their life as long as the masked figure remained.

'Fuck... I don't feel this kind of pressure even inside the tomb!' Sect Leader Yu Jian cursed inwardly, feeling like he's already aged a hundred years in these few short minutes.

Suddenly, a voice resounded in the area.

This voice was calm, soothing to the ears, and as gentle as feathers, yet there was a strikingly domineering feeling to the tone that demanded complete obedience.

"It took you long enough to get here... How long are you going to keep us waiting? Hurry up and get this over with so that you can continue your journey, which is just starting if you just made it here."

To everyone's absolute shock, this voice came from the masked figure. Although everyone doubted their ears at first, they quickly realized that nobody but the masked figure could possibly have the audacity to speak in such a tense situation.

'The Nameless Emperor spoke...? What's he talking about? Has he been waiting for someone this entire time? Who?' Lord Ji was baffled. He has seen the Nameless Emperor over a hundred times in his lifetime but this is the first time he's heard the Nameless Emperor's voice.

Meanwhile, Tian Yanyu was baffled for another reason.

'His voice... It sounds oddly familiar... like I have heard it before...' She moved her eyes to glance at Yuan without turning her head.

'Right... It sounds exactly like Xiao Yang's voice, albeit a little more mature... Or am I just imagining things?' She didn't want to jump to conclusions so she disregarded such thoughts for now.

Shortly after the Nameless Emperor spoke, his body made of spiritual energy began to disperse until there was nothing left.

Normally, the people there would instantly rush into the Nameless Emperor's Tomb after the Nameless Emperor's disappearance, but nobody there made any movements even after he was gone this time.

'Even though you're telling me to hurry, I won't be able to enter the tomb for another five days. Sorry.' Yuan shook his head inwardly.

Eventually, the experts started snapping out of their daze, and they finally started sending people into the Nameless Emperor's Tomb.

"I will see you later, Xiao Yang." Tian Yanyu said when it was their sect's turn to enter.

"Stay safe. We will meet in five days if nothing goes wrong."

Yuan continued to wait outside the tomb until he saw Tian Yanyu enter the Nameless Emperor's Tomb with his own eyes.

Once he confirmed this, he turned around and disappeared from the scene.

"Disciple Tian, what happened to your friend? I thought he was going to enter the tomb with us." Yu Jian, who had been keeping his eyes on Yuan, asked Tian Yanyu and Tian Suyin when he noticed that he didn't enter with them.

"Something came up for him so he'll enter at a later date." Tian Yanyu explained.

"I see... How unfortunate. I would feel a lot safer if I knew that he was in here." Yu Jian shook his head.

Seeing how much the Sect Leader held a junior in such high regard, Tian Suyin could only shake her head inwardly and admit that she felt the same way.

The Jade Sword Manor would continue traveling in the Nameless Emperor's Tomb as a whole sect for a little longer before everyone split up into smaller groups, dispersing in every direction.

Tian Yanyu followed her mother and others that were going to the same destination, quickly making their way towards the Nameless Stone Warrior.

Meanwhile, Yuan returned to Meixiu and the others to let them know of the situation since he had a few more days before the meeting with Xu Jiaqi.

"There's a good chance that I might not leave the Nameless Emperor's Tomb for a while so I am going to leave behind some things for you guys just in case you want to leave the Cultivators' Haven and explore Third Heaven by yourself."

"Exploring the Third Heaven without you? That's suicide for cultivators at our level." Chu Liuxiang said with a bittersweet smile.

"How long do you think it will take?" Meixiu asked.

"At most six months, but I really hope it won't take that long."

"Half a year... Do you think we'll reach at least Spirit Grandmaster in that amount of time?" Li Jinxi asked.

"With your talents and resources, I have no doubt that you'll reach at least Spirit Lord." Yuan smiled.

"By the way, even though I won't be with you, just know that you're still being protected no matter where you are."

"What do you mean?" Meixiu raised an eyebrow.

"I will tell you about it at tonight's dinner table."

"Alright."

Later that night at the dinner table, Yuan would tell Meixiu and the others about the Nameless Emperor's Tomb and his new friend Dong Ye. However, he didn't tell them everything about Dong Ye, such as how Dong Ye was a servant from one of his past lives, as that would've made things complicated. Though, he did tell Meixiu and Chu Liuxiang since they were already aware of his past lives.

Over the next five days, Yuan would spend them in the real world with most of his time being spent in the training field or the bedroom.

Five days passed in the blink of an eye, and it was time for his promise with Xu Jiaqi to be fulfilled.

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Chapter 1108 Strongest Soul Cultivation Technique In The Nine Heavens

A few days prior to her meeting with Yuan, Xu Jiaqi had to retrieve the soul cultivation technique from Lady Xiang.

"I have done what you asked. I want the soul cultivation technique now." Xu Jiaqi said while standing before Lady Xiang.

Lady Xiang lowered her cup of tea and smiled, "I knew you were powerful, but who thought you'd be capable of annihilating the entire Sky Whales Faction overnight. The entire Supreme Heaven is trembling because of your actions, you know. How long has it been since you last stirred the world this much? 100,000 years ago?"

"The soul cultivation technique. I will not repeat myself." Xu Jiaqi even extended her hands out.

Lady Xiang sighed, "Why are you being so impatient? Do you really think I am going to swindle you?"

After placing her tea down, Lady Xiang continued, "I don't know how you think this works, but I cannot just hand you the technique. This soul cultivation technique is a little special, so I will have to transfer it to the individual myself."

Xu Jiaqi narrowed her eyes, "If you're doing this just so you can identify the junior..."

Lady Xiang shrugged, "I won't lie. I am intrigued by this junior whom you're so desperate to help, but I do not have any ulterior motives, nor am I the type to go after someone else's man. I cannot give him the technique unless I do so personally. This is a rule that cannot be broken even if you threaten to kill me."

After a moment of silence, Xu Jiaqi nodded, "Fine. Meet me at the Myriad of Techniques in three days."

And without saying another word, Xu Jiaqi disappeared from Lady Xiang's sight.

"She's as difficult as ever." Lady Xiang shook her head with a bittersweet smile on her face.

Normal people would be irritated by Xu Jiaqi's bossy attitude, but Lady Xiang has known her for millions of years and knew Xu Jiaqi's true personality, so it didn't offend her even the slightest.

Three days later, Lady Xiang entered the Myriad of Techniques, where Xu Jiaqi and Senior Bai were waiting.

"How have you been, Bai Linyu? Are you still being tossed around by Lady Xu?" Lady Xiang asked him in a teasing voice.

"And you seem the same as always, Lady Xiang." Senior Bai smiled at her.

"Don't you mean I look prettier than before?"

"The two of you can chat all you want later, but we have someone waiting for us right now." Xu Jiaqi said.

"Take me to this junior." Lady Xiang smiled.

A few hours before Lady Xiang's arrival, Yuan entered the Myriad of Techniques and met up with Senior Bai.

"You're here early. Lady Xu won't be here for a few more hours." Senior Bai said to him.

"That's fine. If you're free, let's have a chat. I have some questions for you." Yuan said.

"What kind of questions?"

After a moment of silence, Yuan asked, "What do you know about someone named Evil God?"

Senior Bai's eyes widened with shock after hearing this name.

"W-Where did you hear this name?"

"I'm not exactly sure where or when I heard it, but it resurfaced in my mind recently and I can't stop thinking about it since." Yuan lied with a straight face.

"I'm saying this for your own good, but do not look into the Evil God— In fact, don't even utter this name in public. You could be mistaken as the Evil God's Worshiper, which is punishable with immediate death."

"Now I'm even more curious. There's nobody but us here, so it should be fine, right?" Yuan smiled.

Senior Bai sighed, "If I quench your thirst, can you promise me that you will stop looking into it?"

Yuan quickly nodded.

After taking a deep breath, Senior Bai spoke, "The Evil God was one of the strongest and most dangerous individuals to have ever existed in the Nine Heavens. Nobody knows his true identity, but he showed up out of the blue one day and declared war on the Celestial Emperor— the first Celestial Emperor in history."

"This occurred somewhere in the middle of an ongoing war called the Heavenly War of Immortals and Gods when the cultivators fighting the Celestial Emperor were losing. The Evil God's appearance changed the direction of the war."

"Heavenly War of Immortals and Gods... I heard of this war before. What was the cause of it?" Yuan asked.

"The rogue cultivators didn't like how the Celestial Emperor limited the resources in the Nine Heavens, restricting its access to only those that served under him, so they revolted. This rebellion rocked the entire Nine Heavens, even splitting it into 9 separate worlds in the process."

"And the Evil God joined this war in the middle of it, killing the Celestial Emperor?" Yuan asked for confirmation.

"That's right."

"And nobody knows why?"

"Perhaps a few close to him knew the real reason, but the majority of us do not."

"Speaking of people close to him, I remember the name Dong Ye being mentioned alongside the Evil God. Do you know anything about him?"

Senior Bai pondered for a moment before speaking, "If I remember correctly, Dong Ye was the commander of the Evil God's Shadow Army, one of the most fearsome groups of assassins within the Nine Heavens."

Yuan would continue to ask questions about the Evil God, and Senior Bai would answer them to the best of his knowledge.

A few hours later, Senior Bai said, "Alright, it's about time. I'm going to get Lady Xu now."

"Okay. Thank you for your time."

"Remember your promise."

Yuan nodded with a smile, "I know. I won't look into the Evil God anymore."

Senior Bai left the Myriad of Techniques the next moment.

A few minutes later, Yuan could sense Senior Bai's presence reappearing nearby, alongside two other presences, one of which that he did not recognize.

'Who is that?' Yuan wondered to himself as he gazed at the unfamiliar beauty that was following Senior Bai and Xu Jiaqi.

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Chapter 1109 Strongest Soul Cultivation Technique In The Nine Heavens(2)

"Good morning, Miss Xu, Senior." Yuan bowed to them in a respectful manner when they got close enough.

"We've kept you waiting." Xu Jiaqi nodded her head in acknowledgment.

"There's still a few days before the agreed date." Yuan smiled.

He turned to look at Lady Xiang whom he was unfamiliar with, but he didn't want to be noosy, so he didn't ask for her identity.

'She seems a bit dazed for some reason.' He thought to himself.

Xu Jiaqi also noticed this, so she decided to introduce Lady Xiang instead.

"This is Lady Xiang from the Divine Essence Monastery. You probably haven't heard of this place since they only exist in the upper heavens, but they're one of the top 10 powers in the Nine Heavens. As for her reason for being here—"

"I am here to teach you my soul cultivation technique." Lady Xiang suddenly spoke, interrupting Xu Jiaqi.

"My apologies for the late introduction. I had something on my mind just now. I am Xiang Biyu, the current Holy Maiden of the Divine Essence Monastery. You may address me as Sister Biyu."

Senior Bai and Xu Jiaqi looked at Lady Xiang with raised eyebrows. Why would Lady Xiang allow Yuan to address her with such familiarity despite this being their first meeting?

Lady Xiang continued without pausing, "In my possession is what I believe to be the strongest soul cultivation technique in the Nine Heavens, so Lady Xu went to the right person if that's what she— you are looking for."

"Tell me, why are you seeking such a powerful technique when you're just a mere Spirit King? Did you not stop to think that you might be biting more than you can chew?"

Yuan smiled and said, "I was just looking for a suitable soul cultivation technique. It was Miss Xu who offered to find me the best one she could find. There's no way I could refuse such an offer. As for whether or not I can chew it... I guess we will find out once I bite into it."

Lady Xiang glanced at Xu Jiaqi for a second but didn't say anything.

"Fortunately for you, unlike most soul cultivation techniques out there, my soul cultivation technique doesn't discriminate against one's cultivation, so anyone can learn it as long as they qualify. However, that is easier said than done, as there have only been three people since ancient time that have managed to learn this soul cultivation technique."

"Only three people...?" Yuan was surprised to hear this, but he was also excited. After all, the harder it was to learn something, that something is usually more unique and powerful.

"If you do not have what it takes to learn this soul cultivation technique, there is nothing I could do for you. It just means you are not fated to learn it." Lady Xiang said a moment later.

She turned to look at Lady Xu and continued, "As I have mentioned before coming here, if he doesn't learn it, don't expect any compensation, as this was part of our deal."

"I am well aware." Xu Jiaqi nodded.

Lady Xiang returned to Yuan and smiled, "She destroyed an entire faction just to get you this chance, young man. Try not to waste it— even if you don't really have a choice."

"You did what?" Yuan looked at Xu Jiaqi with wide eyes.

"Don't misunderstand. Even though it was part of the agreement, the Celestial Overlords have a duty to deal with any Demon Worshippers, so I would've dealt with them the moment I learned that they were Demon Worshippers even if it wasn't part of the agreement."

"Whatever you say, Lady Xu."

Lady Xiang proceeded to glare at Yuan with a serious look on her face.

"Are you ready?" She asked.

"I am." He nodded.

"Let's go." Xu Jiaqi suddenly said to Senior Bai, who nodded in silence.

The two of them proceeded to leave Lady Xiang and Yuan alone.

Since Lady Xiang only promised to teach Yuan the soul cultivation technique, it was only natural for everyone else to leave.

Once they were alone, Lady Xiang spoke, "This technique is a little special, so the learning method will be a little special as well. Though, it's quite simple."

Lady Xiang closed her eyes, and her aura suddenly began to soar.

A few moments later, a massive golden bell materialized behind her.

This bell didn't appear to be completely solid and seemed somewhat semi-transparent. It was the size of a four-story building, and it emanated an otherworldly aura.

Upon closer inspection, Yuan could see tiny words engraved onto the front of the bell, exactly 1,000 words.

"Is that the soul cultivation technique inscribed on the bell?" Yuan asked.

"Indeed. It may seem very insignificant compared to even the most ordinary technique, but each word encompasses a profound secret that will lead you closer to learning the technique."

"What is this technique's name?"

"You will learn it if you are fated to. Otherwise, you are not worthy to know its name." Lady Xiang said.

Yuan's gaze was fixated on the golden bell ever since it came into view, looking as though he was bewitched by it.

"It could take weeks, months, even years to learn this technique. I will give you fifty years." Lady Xiang said a moment later.

Although 50 years may sound a lot, it would feel no different than a few weeks for an Immortal who has lived millions of years. Furthermore, it took Lady Xiang, one of the most talented individuals in her era, 120 years to learn the technique, so 50 years was actually very little time.

However, almost as though he couldn't hear her, Yuan remained silent.

Lady Xiang continued speaking regardless, "Once you think you have comprehended the technique, ring the bell with your spiritual energy. Even a little is fine. Once you do, the bell will ring, and each ring will signify your understanding, so the more times it rings, the more you'll comprehend it."

'I doubt you'll be able to learn this technique in 50 years, but there's no need to worry, because I will—'

In the midst of Lady Xiang's thoughts, Yuan suddenly lifted his finger and pointed it at the bell.

And before Lady Xiang could even wonder what he was thinking, Yuan released a strand of spiritual energy that flew straight at the bell.

"What are you—?!" Lady Xiang exclaimed in a shocked voice after seeing his seemingly reckless actions, but she had no time to be shocked, as Yuan would surely be dead before the bell could even finish ringing once.

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Chapter 1110 Strongest Soul Cultivation Technique In The Nine Heavens(3)

The moment Yuan's spiritual energy touched the bell, its golden figure began to tremble, and a second later, almost as though someone had struck it with a wooden log, it released a heart-throbbing noise that swept the entire world.

DONG!

Yuan could feel his entire body trembling with the bell, and it felt like his very soul had been struck alongside the bell.

"Do you have a death wish?! If you ring the bell before you comprehend the technique, it could shatter your very soul!" Lady Xiang cried out loud after hearing the first ring.

However, there was nothing she could do about it, as once the bell rings, it would not stop until the very end, and whether Yuan's soul will survive the ordeal was entirely up to him.

"Don't worry, I have already comprehended the technique." Yuan spoke in a calm voice as the first ring continued to echo.

The sound of each ring lasted nine seconds, so he had some time until the next one.

"What in heavens' name are you talking about?! That's impossible! It took me 120 years to comprehend the technique while you've just started!" Lady

Xiang didn't want to believe it— she couldn't. In fact, nobody in the Nine Heavens would believe Yuan's outrageous claims.

However, Yuan wasn't lying. Almost as though he was fated to learn the technique— or he learned the technique in advance, he'd instantly grasped the meaning behind the words on the bell at glance and comprehended the technique the following second.

It was so unbelievably easy that even Yuan doubted it at first, hence why he went ahead and rang the golden bell, as he suddenly had this uncontrollable urge to do so, which was probably affected by the technique he'd just comprehended.

With that being said, while he's comprehended the technique, he hasn't actually learned it yet.

How much of the technique he learns will entirely depend on the amount of times the bell resounds. Thus, the more the bell rings, the more he will learn the technique.

Nine seconds after the first ring, the bell rang for a second time, sounding even louder than the previous.

DONG!!!

Yuan could feel his entire body being pushed back by the noise as well as the invisible force that was pressuring his internal organs and his very soul.

Despite that, it didn't really affect Yuan too much, and the pressure on his soul was nothing more than just that. He wasn't hurt by the pressure, nor did he feel like his life was threatened by it.

Therefore, Yuan stood tall and endured the second bell for nine more seconds.

After the second ringing ended, the bell resounded for a third time— but not before the golden bell itself grew in size.

And in the blink of an eye, the golden bell nearly doubled in size.

DONG!!!

Lady Xiang swallowed nervously as an expression of disbelief was plastered all over her face.

'He's withstanding the pressure from the bell... Did he really comprehend the technique in that short of a time? How many times will the bell ring for him?'

Lady Xiang recalled her experience learning the technique and facing the bell. After spending 120 years trying to comprehend the technique, she managed to make the golden bell ring a total of 6 times out of a possible 9.

DONG!

The golden bell rang for the fourth time, and it had grown so large that it was almost as big as Yuan's God of War's Astral Art's avatar.

Yuan had closed his eyes and sat down long ago, and his understanding for the soul cultivation technique deepened with every ring.

Eventually, the loud noise sounded no different than music to his ears, and his body felt like it was being embraced by the goddess of sounds.

DONG! DONG!!!

The fifth and sixth ring resounded shortly after.

'Six! He's managed to make the golden bell ring six times!'

DONG!

In what seemed like a blink of an eye, the seventh bell rang.

At the seventh ring, the power of the noise had transcended their space and leaked to the outside world where Xu Jiaqi and the others were waiting.

"Is this... the sound of a bell?" Senior Bai turned around to look at the portal behind him.

"What are they doing inside?" He wondered out loud.

"Whatever they are doing, I have a bad feeling about this." Xu Jiaqi said with a slight frown on her face.

Dong!!!

When the eighth bell rang, Xu Jiaqi and Senior Bai felt the entire world around them tremble.

"What is happening?!" Senior Bai exclaimed.

Xu Jiaqi didn't say anything. She turned around and rushed back into the portal to see what was going on inside. Senior Bai quickly followed.

And to their absolute surprise, there was a massive golden bell inside Senior Bai's world, and it was big enough to cover the entire place.

"What in Heavens' name are we seeing?" Senior Bai uttered in a voice of disbelief.

Despite the loud noises, neither Senior Bai nor Xu Jiaqi were affected by it, as the pressure was mostly focused on Yuan, so the most they felt was their heart beating louder than usual.

'E-Eight rings...' Lady Xiang could be seen trembling in shock even from a distance.

Xu Jiaqi immediately approached her and asked, "What the hell is going on here?!"

Lady Xiang turned to look at her with wide eyes before speaking in a dazed voice, "H-He's managed to make the bell ring eight times..."

"What is that even supposed to mean?" Xu Jiaqi frowned.

"It means a new legend is about to be born!" She exclaimed with a wide smile on her face.

DONG!!!

The golden bell rang for the ninth time, causing the entire Nine Heavens to tremble, and Lady Xiang could feel her excitement reaching its climax when she heard this.

However, little did Lady Xiang know that this was just the beginning.

After the golden bell rang nine times, it suddenly rang again for the tenth time.

DONG!

Lady Xiang always believed that the golden bell could only ring a maximum of nine times, but Yuan had managed to surpass that and ring it 10 times!

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Chapter 1111 The Nine Heavens Trembles!

After the 10th ring, the golden bell fell silent, but both Yuan and Lady Xiang could somehow tell that it wasn't completely over yet.

"Tell me, what's going on?" Xu Jiaqi asked them, as she was completely clueless to the situation.

"Once one comprehends the soul cultivation technique, the golden bell will ring a certain number of times with nine— ten rings being the maximum, and the more times you manage to make it ring, the stronger your understanding of the technique will be. In other words, the more it rings the better." Lady Xiang explained in a dazed voice.

And she continued, "For reference, I made the bell ring six times when I comprehended the technique, and I was considered a genius that would appear only once every few million years."

After swallowing nervously, she said, "Your little friend here has managed to make the bell ring ten times... that kind of talent is frightening. I cannot imagine what kind of monster he'll be like in the future."

Although it might be a bit rude to call Yuan a monster, Lady Xiang could not think of another term to call him by, and his talent was truly monstrous.

"So what happens now?" Xu Jiaqi asked.

Lady Xiang shook her head, "I don't know. The golden bell should've disappeared after it stopped ringing, but it's still here for some reason, so it

might not be the end just yet. As for what might happen, I cannot even begin to imagine."

"..."

After a brief moment of silence, Xu Jiaqi spoke while staring at Yuan, who was still sitting there with his eyes closed, "How are you feeling?"

"..."

However, almost as though he couldn't even hear her, Yuan remained silent.

Xu Jiaqi didn't try to speak to him again, fearing that she might disturb his trance.

Thus, both Xu Jiaqi and Lady Xiang would patiently wait for Yuan to wake up.

Yuan would not move a single muscle for the next 24 hours, and neither did Xu Jiaqi or Lady Xiang. They would stare at Yuan's face intently, their thoughts unknown. Senior Bai was still waiting outside the portal, feeling a little nervous about how silent it was.

Fortunately, that silence would not last too long, as the Nine Heavens would soon experience another turmoil.

Once 24 hours had passed, Yuan suddenly opened his eyes, but they seemed empty, almost as though he was still unconscious.

A profound aura suddenly swept the world, followed by the deafening sound of a bell ringing.

The golden bell has started to ring again for the 11th time, but it was much quicker this time.

Unlike the slow ringing at the start, the pace became much quicker, and the golden bell would ring every second.

DONG! DONG! DONG!

Every ring would send out a ripple with unfathomable secrets that filled the small world before leaking out into the Nine Heavens.

The Nine Heavens would tremble every time the bell rang, so it would shake every second, causing a major uproar in every world within the Nine Heavens.

This constant shaking made many people wonder if the world was ending, and more people would begin to have the same thoughts when the trembling grew stronger and stronger.

Somewhere in the Nine Heavens, the Celestial Emperor stood before his throne with his hands wrapped into a tight fist and a dazed look on his face.

He could hear the faint sound of a bell ringing that was getting clearer with every passing second, almost as though he was standing before the bell himself, and he recalled a certain sentence.

"When the glorious Bell of Supremacy resounds, a new ruler is born, and the Nine Heavens will tremble as it enters a new era."

"Have you returned once again to trample on this world's peace? Why won't you give up? No matter how many times you reincarnate, you cannot escape the fate bestowed upon everyone born under this heaven. It's impossible to win..."

The Celestial Emperor had a tired and somewhat defeated look in his eyes.

Back in the Myriad of Techniques, Yuan could feel something deep within his body being loosened— being awakened.

As the bell approached its 90th ring, Yuan finally understood one thing.

'This has nothing to do with the soul cultivation technique. This is a key... a key to a lock within me. Something inside me is being unsealed.'

Although he didn't know what was being unsealed, he somehow knew that it would help him face whatever was inside the Nameless Emperor's Tomb.

Once the golden bell rang a total of 99 times, it would stop for a few seconds before resounding one more time.

When the golden bell rang for the 100th time, it shattered into countless fragments.

These fragments did not immediately disappear and instead transformed into golden swords that pointed at Yuan.

Each of these swords had unique symbols engraved into them, but neither Xu Jiaqi nor Lady Xiang could read them.

As for Yuan, even though he couldn't read them, he could somehow understand them.

Whoosh!

These countless golden swords suddenly flew at Yuan, entering his body without harming him in the slightest.

Once Yuan absorbed all of the golden swords, he took a deep breath before closing his eyes and entering into another trance.

This trance didn't last as long and ended a few minutes later.

When he opened his eyes, it was pure gold and glistening like stars in a starry night, giving an otherworldly feeling to his existence.

Both Xu Jiaqi and Lady Xiang subconsciously swallowed nervously when they saw his eyes, feeling as though they were before a divine entity despite being god-like existences themselves.

"I think it's over," he spoke in a calm voice a moment later.

However, the goddesses were still in shock and trying to process what had just happened.

"H-How do you feel?" Lady Xiang asked him a moment later.

"I feel fine."

"Just fine? Do you feel any different?"

To her surprise, Yuan shook his head, "No, I don't feel any different."

"How is that even possible...?" Lady Xiang muttered in a dazed voice.

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Chapter 1112 Lady Xiang's Offer

"I don't believe it." Xu Jiaqi suddenly spoke with a cold expression on her face.

"You just learned the strongest soul cultivation technique known in the Nine Heavens, not to mention that spectacle just now. There's no way you don't feel any different."

Yuan shook his head with a bittersweet smile, "Why would I lie to you? I truly don't feel any different. Perhaps the effects will start showing later, but I can't sense anything different about my body at this moment."

Neither Lady Xiang nor Xu Jiaqi could argue with his logic, especially when they still cannot comprehend what had just occurred.

"Then I would like to make a suggestion. You should stay here for a little longer so that I can monitor your condition." Lady Xiang then said.

"I'm sorry, Lady Xiang, but I have somewhere to be, and I already broke my promise once. I cannot disappoint my friend a second time. I hope you can understand. If I feel any different, I will let Senior Bai know."

Lady Xiang frowned, clearly unhappy, which was to be expected. However, what Yuan didn't expect was what she would go on to say.

"That's not right. I told you to address me as Sister Biyu." Lady Xiang revealed her reason for being displeased, leaving Yuan speechless.

Xu Jiaqi then spoke, "You don't need to report anything if you don't want to. We just wanted to make sure your body is unharmed after enduring the golden bell for so long."

If it is considered rude to question a cultivator about their gains after they consumed a treasure, the same logic applied to cultivation techniques.

"Anyways, about the soul cultivation technique... Do you have it?" Lady Xiang asked a moment later.

Yuan silently nodded.

Lady Xiang took a deep breath before speaking, "Not only did you surpass me in comprehension, you even made the golden bell ring 110 times. I don't think something like this will ever be surpassed or repeated again."

"Junior Brother Yuan, would you like to be my disciple?" Lady Xiang suddenly offered to be his master.

"If you become my disciple, I will immediately bring you to the Supreme Heaven, and I will spare no resources nurturing you. All of my disciples have become a powerhouse in the Nine Heavens one way or another, and with your talents, you will surely be my brightest disciple yet. Moreover, since our soul cultivation technique is very unique, I am the only person in the Nine Heavens who can guide you properly in that regard."

"Although the Divine Essence Monastery is a female-only sect and I have only ever accepted female disciples before, I will make an exception for you. You will not only be surrounded by beauties, they're the most brilliant and beautiful flowers you can encounter in the Nine Heavens. If that's not enough to satisfy you, I don't mind offering myself to you. I may have lived a long time, but as the Holy Maiden, my body is still pure." Lady Xiang winked at the end.

Yuan was speechless. How did the conversation go off the rails so fast within a single sentence?

"Hey, what nonsense are you spouting? I'll kill you." Xu Jiaqi interrupted with a cold look on her face.

Lady Xiang remained calm despite Xu Jiaqi's threatening aura, and she even smiled, "Nonsense? I did not utter a single lie just now. In case you

forgot, you also studied under me at one point."

"That was because my father..."

"No matter how you put it, you cannot alter the truth."

Xu Jiaqi rubbed her eyes and sighed, "Yuan, ignore her. She may be the Holy Maiden, but she acts anything but one. Even if she is the only person in this world who can teach you about the soul cultivation technique, I have a feeling that you won't need it. In fact, you might even be the one guiding her in the future."

"How can you say such a thing in front of a junior right before my presence, Little Qi? To make things fair, how about I reveal some of your embarrassing secrets?" Lady Xiang spoke with a cold look on her face.

"I thought I told you that I would kill you if you ever utter that name again..." Xu Jiaqi's eyes flickered with killing intent.

Sensing that things were getting out of hand, Yuan cleared his throat and spoke in a stiff voice, "Seniors, please calm down. You're both my benefactors. I cannot bear to watch the two of you fight with each other."

He then turned to look at Lady Xiang and continued, "As for your offer, Lady— Sister Biyu, I'm sorry, but I will have to decline."

"May I ask for your reason?" Lady Xiang asked, her expression turned serious.

"There are still things that I must do— questions that I need to find answers for down here before I ascend to the Supreme Heaven. I have already decided to climb every step of the way to the Supreme Heaven, so I cannot let you take me there." Yuan explained.

After all, he won't be able to recover his memories if he skipped all the way to the end.

Lady Xiang closed her eyes and released a long sigh, "If that's your decision, I won't force it."

While she really wanted to accept Yuan as a disciple, she already expected for him to refuse. However, even if Yuan accepted her offer, she wouldn't have actually accepted him as her disciple for one simple yet complex reason— a reason that she cannot reveal to either Yuan or Xu Jiaqi.

"Junior Brother, I won't pursue this issue any further, but I have another request. Let's meet again in this place after three months. I want to see how much you've progressed with the soul cultivation technique." Lady Xiang said.

"Three months... I might not be able to make it, as I will be entering the Nameless Emperor's Tomb, which could last for as long as half a year." Yuan said.

"Nameless Emperor's Tomb...? You're actually going inside that torture chamber? What are you, a masochist?" Xu Jiaqi couldn't help but utter these words.

"You've been inside before?" Yuan had a feeling this was the case.

"Of course. In fact, most of the Immortals in the Supreme Heaven have explored the Nameless Emperor's Tomb at least once. Despite this place existing in the Third Heaven, it is still dangerous enough that even Immortals have perished inside. While inside, everyone above Spirit King will have their cultivation restricted to peak Spirit King, and all spiritual treasures above Ancient-grade are rendered useless, so the only advantages we have are our knowledge, experience, and techniques." Xu Jiaqi said.

Yuan swallowed nervously after hearing all of this.

The Nameless Emperor's Tomb is dangerous enough to kill even Immortals that are entities that he cannot even comprehend yet? Why does such a place even exist? He couldn't wait to find out.

"Now that I know you're planning to explore the Nameless Emperor's Tomb, I cannot leave you empty-handed." Lady Xiang suddenly said.

"Here are some life—"

Right as Lady Xiang prepared to pull out life-saving treasures for Yuan, Xu Jiaqi stopped her and said, "What are you doing? Have you forgotten our position? If we interfere too much, it could have the opposite effect and harm him instead."

"..." Lady Xiang wanted to argue, but she couldn't.

"Fine, I won't give him any life-saving treasures, but I won't let him go inside without anything." Lady Xiang said with a stern look on her face. "Even though he's not my official disciple, he still learned my soul cultivation technique, so he is technically one."

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Chapter 1113 Lady Xiang's Blessing

"Come over here, Junior Brother." Lady Xiang gestured for Yuan. "You may not need this, but it's better to be safe than be sorry."

Yuan nodded, and he approached her while anticipating what she was going to give him.

Once he was right in front of Lady Xiang, she said, "Close your eyes."

Yuan didn't question her request and closed his eyes.

The following moment, he would feel something soft and small pressing against his forehead, which prompted him to open his eyes.

When he opened his eyes, Yuan could only see a pair of luscious breasts hovering right in front of his face, causing him to raise an eyebrow.

Xu Jiaqi's mouth was wide open at this moment as her shocked eyes were glaring at Lady Xiang, who was giving Yuan a kiss on the forehead.

As the Holy Maiden, her actions right now would be considered a taboo, and it would surely create an uproar if the public knew of it.

The kiss didn't last long, only three seconds, but it felt like three hours to Xu Jiaqi. Perhaps it would've lasted longer if Xu Jiaqi didn't intervene.

"Are you done yet?"

Lady Xiang removed her lips from Yuan's forehead with a satisfied smile on her face.

"I've just given you a blessing. It will automatically activate if it senses that you're in grave danger. I hope it will never activate, though."

"Thank you." Yuan smiled back, not thinking too much about the kiss on the forehead.

Sometime later, Xu Jiaqi spoke, "Regarding your other request— about your physique. Unfortunately, I didn't have time to get the manuals since I came here immediately after getting the technique. When you return in six months, I will also be here with the manuals."

"I understand. Thank you, Miss Xu."

"Before you leave, there is one more topic that needs to be discussed." Xu Jiaqi then said.

"What is it?"

Xu Jiaqi proceeded to tell Yuan about the situation in the Supreme Heaven and how many powerful Sects, Factions, and Clans had sent down people to hunt for a certain individual.

Yuan began sweating when he heard this information. Even though Xu Jiaqi said that they didn't know the true identity of this criminal yet, he knew right away when she mentioned Heavens' Judgment, and he pondered if he should tell her the truth.

"Honestly, even though I am telling you this, I am not telling you to hunt this criminal. Even if you come across this person, you aren't obligated to catch him. There are plenty of people who are capable of dealing with a mere criminal in Third Heaven. Though, you will receive a lot of good karma if you do, so there's that."

"I understand... I will try my best to catch him if I see him." Yuan said with a stiff smile on his face.

"Here. Take this jade slip. It will burn if you're close to the criminal, who had been branded by Heaven during the judgment." Xu Jiaqi handed Yuan a

black jade slip.

Yuan silently stared at the jade slip with a dazed look on his face. He was wondering why the jade slip had no reaction even though he was right in front of it. Not that he had any complaints, as this situation worked in his favor.

After accepting the jade slip, Yuan left the Myriad of Techniques shortly after.

"So he's already left, huh? I still have something to give him, but that will have to wait until our next meeting now." Senior Bai mumbled after learning that Yuan had left.

"He'll return in six months after the Nameless Emperor's Tomb." Xu Jiaqi briefly explained the situation.

"Nameless Emperor's Tomb! Even with his talents, I cannot help but feel a little worried." Senior Bai shook his head.

The Nameless Emperor's Tomb could be considered one of the most difficult Legacy Tombs in the Nine Heavens, after all.

"Why are you still here?" Xu Jiaqi turned to look at Lady Xiang, who was still lingering around for some reason.

Lady Xiang did not immediately respond and silently stared at her.

After a moment of silence, she asked in a low voice, "Judging by how you're acting around that young man... Don't tell me you can't see the resemblance?"

"What are you talking about?" Xu Jiaqi looked genuinely puzzled by such a question.

"Unbelievable..." Lady Xiang sighed.

"Actually, now that I think about it, you weren't there to see his growth, so it's not that surprising that you don't see it..."

"What the hell have you been mumbling about since the beginning? You are acting weird today— very weird."

"If you don't understand it, then I won't bother." Lady Xiang shook her head.

Naturally, she was referring to how Yuan resembled the founder of the Celestial Overlords.

Unlike Xu Jiaqi, who was picked up by the founder when she was just a little girl, Lady Xiang had been with him since much earlier, as early as his teenage years.

'The resemblance is so uncanny that I thought I'd somehow traveled to the past...' Lady Xiang sighed inwardly as she recalled her memories that are so old they can be considered ancient.

As she reached the exit, Lady Xiang turned around to look at Xu Jiaqi again.

"He's probably already part of the Celestial Overlord, right?" She asked.

"Naturally." Xu Jiaqi spoke in a manner that made it seem like there was no other option.

"Then I will give up recruiting him to my faction for now. Though, I will acquire him through other ways. Don't say I didn't warn you." Lady Xiang waved at Xu Jiaqi as she entered the exit, leaving Xu Jiaqi no time to respond.

"Lady Xu, what happened? The Nine Heavens shook nonstop just now. This is the second time it's happened. I don't think this is a coincidence anymore."

After a moment of silence, Xu Jiaqi mumbled, "It's definitely connected to Yuan. As for why it's happening, I don't have the slightest clue, nor is it our business. I'm leaving now."

Chapter 1114 Heaven's Indomitable Soul

After leaving the Myriad of Techniques, Yuan immediately began making his way back to the Nameless Emperor's Tomb.

On his way there, he would think about the new cultivation technique that he'd just acquired.

<Heaven's Indomitable Soul>

<Rank: ???>

<Mastery Level: ???>

<Description: A technique of unknown origins. Absorb the very essence of this world and convert it into your Soul Strength.>

As he couldn't wait to experience the technique, Yuan decided to use the technique while he was on the move to see how it worked.

Immediately after he activated the technique, Yuan could feel his body absorbing the spiritual essence around him, almost like how cultivators absorb Qi when they cultivate. However, spiritual essence was different from spiritual energy.

Unlike spiritual energy that will inevitably have impurity, spiritual essence is completely pure, so the cultivator won't need to cleanse its purity after absorbing.

Furthermore, spiritual essence itself is much stronger than spiritual energy, making it the ideal resource for all cultivators. However, one does not

simply cultivate spiritual essence normally.

In order to absorb spiritual essence, one must be able to sense spiritual essence, something that is only doable after they become an immortal.

In other words, Yuan, who was still a mere Spirit King, could absorb spiritual essence and achieve what even immortals find difficult. That's not all. Not only could he absorb spiritual essence, but he can even convert it into his soul strength, something only those that have learned Heaven's Indomitable Soul technique could achieve.

There is even a popular saying in the Supreme Heavens that says a single drop of spiritual essence is more valuable than a whole sea of spiritual energy, as spiritual energy essentially becomes useless to Immortals, who can only grow through spiritual essence.

Yuan could feel an overwhelming feeling suddenly wash over him, almost like a pillar in the middle of the ocean, where the water would continuously refresh his body, mind, and soul.

<+2,021 Soul Strength>

<+3,000 Soul Strength>

<+2,391 Soul Strength>

Every few seconds, his Soul Strength would increase by the thousands. If the world knew of this, they would surely be shocked to death.

'My divine sense is expanding at a ludicrous rate...' Yuan thought to himself as his divine sense reaches over 100 miles, and it was still growing with every passing second.

Xiao Hua could sense something was going on around Yuan even though she couldn't sense spiritual essence.

"Brother Yuan, are you okay?" She asked him.

"Yes, I am just testing out the new soul cultivation technique. It's quite powerful. My Soul Strength is increasing by the second."

"What kind of effect does it have?" Feng Yuxiang asked out of curiosity.

"It absorbs spiritual essence and converts them into my Soul Strength."

"What?! You can absorb spiritual essence already?!" Unsurprisingly, Feng Yuxiang exclaimed in a shocked voice after hearing this information.

"Only those that have succeeded their Immortal Ascension should be able to do such a thing!"

Out of everything Yuan has done up to this point, his ability to absorb spiritual essence as a mere Spirit King was the most shocking by far, not to mention that he could even convert it into Soul Strength.

For comparison, it was akin to a mortal learning cultivation techniques only comprehensible by gods, or a mortal casually wielding a godly artifact that would normally kill anyone that isn't powerful enough to wield it.

"Yuan... You should keep this information a secret." Lan Yingying suddenly spoke in a worried voice.

"She's right, Brother Yuan. If the world knew, all of the powerful cultivators out there would definitely try to kill you because of your potential, especially Immortals, who would be filled with jealousy and anger if they knew that a Spirit King could use their spiritual essence." Xiao Hua said.

Most Immortals consider the ability to absorb spiritual essence an honor—something they had to shed blood and tears for thousands of years to acquire, yet Yuan, who wasn't even a hundred years old, could use it. His existence was offensive in itself to these Immortals.

By the time Yuan returned to the Nameless Emperor's Tomb, his Soul Strength has increased by over 10 million.

To put into perspective how much that is— even Spirit Sovereigns wouldn't have a third of that.

At his level, his divine sense could cover over a thousand miles with ease, and he could even keep it active for weeks without any breaks.

In fact, even if they had a powerful soul cultivation technique, it would take most cultivators over a hundred years to amass 10 million Soul Strength, something Yuan achieved in a few mere hours.

'It's been a week since the Nameless Emperor's Tomb opened, but it's still as crowded as the first day.' Yuan thought to himself as he was surrounded by people.

And because there were so many people, the entrance was blocked by the Ji Family, as they were controlling the amount of people entering at a time.

[If you wish to enter the Nameless Emperor's Tomb as a rogue cultivator, you must pay a fee of 1,000 spirit stones!]

These words were written on a large banner that hung above the tomb.

"The hell? We have to pay to enter? And a thousand spirit stones... That seems a bit too excessive." Yuan was speechless.

"This is how they keep the tomb from being overflowing with people. Though, this will only apply to rogue cultivators. All disciples and members of big families will still be allowed to enter for free, and since you're a Spirit King, you should also be able to enter without needing to pay." Feng Yuxiang said.

Sometime later, Yuan approached the entrance while wearing the Jade Sword Manor's guest robe.

When the Ji Family saw his clothes and sensed that he was a peak Spirit King, they allowed him to enter the tomb without any troubles.

"Best of luck to you, Senior." The members of the Ji Family mistook Yuan as a senior who was disguised as a young man due to his cultivation base.

Yuan didn't bother trying to correct them and proceeded towards the portal, stepping inside the Nameless Emperor's Tomb a moment later.

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Chapter 1115 Entering Nameless Emperor's Tomb

Upon entering the Nameless Emperor's Tomb, Yuan was teleported to a vast green plain that was filled with hills and healthy tall grass.

The first thing Yuan noticed was the oddity in the air, as it felt denser than what he was used to, and even the gravity there felt heavier than usual.

"Most of the spiritual energy in this world is created by the Nameless Emperor, so what you're feeling right now is that." Feng Yuxiang said when she noticed his expression.

"What are your plans now?"

After a moment of silence, he spoke, "As planned, I will meet up with Tian Yanyu to make sure she's doing okay and see if she needs any assistance, then I will explore this Nameless Plain for a bit before diving deeper."

The majority of the outer area within the tomb was known as the Nameless Plain, and as its name suggests, it was a massive plain that is filled with powerful magical beasts, fortunes, and opportunity.

Yuan closed his eyes and took a moment to recall the map of the Nameless Emperor's Tomb that he'd memorized within the Jade Sword Manor.

Once he found the direction to the Nameless Stone Warrior, Yuan immediately took to the blue sky and began flying towards that direction.

The destination wasn't too far away, so he reached it after flying for four hours straight.

On his way to the Nameless Stone Warrior, Yuan encountered many powerful magical beasts as well as cultivators that were trying to hunt these magical beasts.

He noticed that the magical beasts inside the tomb did not drop monster cores when defeated. Instead, it supplied those that defeated the magical beast with an abundant amount of spiritual energy directly. Furthermore, some of them even dropped treasures and resources directly, such as pills and spiritual weapons.

Most of the magical beasts that he'd encountered were all at the Spirit Lord realm with a few at the early Spirit King realm.

With the outer area already so dangerous, it was no wonder why the casualty rates were so high inside the tomb. However, with great risk comes great reward, hence why everyone that could afford to risk their life to enter did so.

When Yuan reached the vicinity of the Nameless Stone Warrior, he noticed a group of cultivators surrounding the area, and these cultivators quickly blocked his path when they noticed him.

"This place is already occupied by the Jade Sword Manor, Blue Swallow Sword Sect, and the Lightning Sword Academy."

A small group of disciples stood before Yuan, explaining the situation to him.

Yuan pointed at his own clothes and spoke in a calm voice, "I'm with the Jade Sword Manor."

The disciples glanced at his clothes and sneered, "You think we're stupid? That is simply their guest uniform. Also, anyone can disguise themselves as a disciple. Show me your disciple identity badge and I will let you enter."

"I don't have that, and I won't stay long. I just want to speak with one of their disciples." Yuan said.

"No identification, no entry. That is the rule here." The disciples stood their ground.

"Is this a rule of this place, or simply something you came up with by yourself?"

One of the disciples smirked, "In this place, the strong make the rules."

"Is that so..."

Yuan turned silent after this point.

'The Nameless Stone Warrior is a place where people go for enlightenment. If I cause a commotion here, I might disturb them.'

After pondering for a bit, Yuan retrieved Yu Jian's medallion and showed it to these disciples.

"What about this? It was given to me by Sect Leader Yu Jian himself."

The disciple squinted at the medallion before giving a scoff, "I don't recognize it, so I'm not going to accept it."

Yuan shook his head, "You're making this difficult for no reason. One last chance. We can do this the easy way, or the hard way."

"You dare threaten us?!"

The disciples immediately became heated.

Yuan released a sigh, and right before the disciples could even take their first step, Yuan silently activated Heavenly Domain.

All of the disciples around him instantly fell to their knees as a tyrannical pressure bore down on them.

"H-Help...!"

These disciples could feel their bones cracking and muscles tearing apart just from the pressure alone, their bodies screaming in pain.

Within seconds, blood flowed from their eyes, nose, and ears.

"Oops."

Yuan quickly retracted the Heavenly Domain when he saw this, as he wasn't expecting such an outcome.

'I barely used my spiritual energy, yet I nearly killed them. My soul strength has grown so exponentially in such a short time that I don't know my own strength anymore. I need to be careful now if I don't want to accidentally kill someone.' Yuan swallowed nervously.

"What is going on here?!"

A loud voice suddenly boomed in the vicinity, causing Yuan to shift his attention to the group of elders approaching his direction.

Once the elders arrived, they immediately began inspecting Yuan to try and identify him.

A few of the elders there were from the Jade Sword Manor, so they immediately recognized his esteemed guest uniform. Furthermore, Yuan was still holding their Sect Leader's medallion.

"Who are you, and why did you attack my disciples?" An old man wearing a blue uniform stepped forward and questioned Yuan with an angry expression while the other elders went to treat the disciples by feeding them a healing pill.

Yuan quickly explained himself, but the elder did not seem to be satisfied by it. Yuan couldn't blame the elder, as he'd nearly killed the disciples.

However, before the situation could get any worse, Yu Jian showed up to the scene after being notified by the elders from his sect.

After speaking with the elder from the Blue Swallow Sword Sect, Yu Jian managed to calm the situation.

"I have settled things for now, so you can enter, but that is only for now. They might try to trouble you later, and I can't protect you then." Yu Jian sighed.

"That's fine. Thank you for the assistance." Yuan showed him a calm smile, almost as though he couldn't care less about it.

He entered the area with Yu Jian a moment later while being glared at by the disciples that he'd nearly killed.

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Chapter 1116 Nameless Stone Warrior

A few minutes after his incident with the Blue Swallow Sword Sect, Yuan could see a massive statue of a masked figure standing in the distance.

This figure was clearly the Lord, and he was holding his sword straight in front of him like some kind of knight.

Once he got closer, he could see hundreds if not thousands of people sitting around the statue while staring at it intensively, as if they were trying to poke holes in the statue with their gaze alone.

He quickly found Tian Yanyu and Tian Suyin. They were both sitting towards the middle of the group, located directly behind the statue, which is considered to be the worst spot there, as they were unable to see the Lord or the sword clearly from such an angle. Unfortunately for them, the spots in front of the statue were taken by the high-ranking sect elders and top geniuses of their respective sects.

The Nameless Stone Warrior is a famous location within the Nameless Emperor's Tomb. It used to be a very popular site when it was discovered 1,000 years ago, but when nobody could receive full enlightenment from it even 1,000 years later, not as many people still come to this place.

With that being said, many people still spend a week or two in this place to comprehend what little they can from the statue before moving on. While nobody can fully comprehend the statue entirely, there have been plenty of people who were able to receive some kind of guidance and small enlightenment from the statue.

After all, comprehending even half of the statue would grant the individual a massive boost to their strength and understanding of the sword.

And unbeknownst to these people, the moment Yuan glanced at the statue, he was able to comprehend it entirely.

<You have learned Moon Splitting Sword Art>

<Rank: Divine>

<Mastery Level: 1>

<Description: A devastating sword technique with enough prowess to split even the moon in half!>

"..."

Yuan was speechless. It would normally take him a few days if not weeks to learn a Divine-rank technique, yet he'd managed to do it at glance this time.

'Is this because I am the Lord's reincarnation, or is this due to my soul strength?' Yuan wondered inwardly.

Though, despite learning this sword technique, Yuan didn't really need it, as it was just a Divine-rank technique. Unless it was Ancient-rank or higher, it won't make Yuan budge an eyebrow.

After silently learning the technique, Yuan hovered above Tian Yanyu, who currently has her eyes closed and seemingly in a trance, and he patiently waited for her to finish.

About two hours later, Tian Yanyu opened her eyes, which flickered with a sense of frustration.

"How did it go? Did you comprehend anything?" Yuan asked her using divine sense, as he did not want to disturb the others by speaking out loud.

"Xiao Yang! When did you arrive?" She appeared pleasant to see him.

"I got here not long ago."

"I see... Well, I have been here since day 1, but I have only comprehended about 15 percent... probably. My understanding of the sword has increased substantially from it, but I really want to learn the technique it's hiding. Even though I can only comprehend the first four sword movements, it was more than enough to convince me of its prowess. I cannot imagine how powerful the full technique is. It's definitely a Heaven-rank or higher technique."

Tian Yanyu's voice was filled with awe and longing as she spoke of the technique.

However, she was also disappointed in herself. Her group had only planned to stay at the Nameless Stone Warrior for a week, so she had only a day or so left to comprehend as much as she could, but it was clearly not enough time to learn the technique.

Furthermore, even if she was given a hundred years to comprehend the technique, there was no guarantee that she could fully comprehend the technique.

After a moment of silence, Yuan suddenly asked her, "If you really want to learn this technique, shall I teach it to you? I managed to fully comprehend it, so I can just directly teach you the technique"

"YOU WHAT?!" Tian Yanyu's shocked and no doubt deafening voice suddenly boomed in the area that had been completely silent for the past six days, startling everyone there.

A few people there even puked out blood after their enlightenment had been interrupted by Tian Yanyu's sudden outburst.

"W-W-Who the fuck shouted just now?! How dare you! I was in the middle of enlightenment! Now it's all ruined! Fucking fuck!"

"I was also very close to enlightenment as well! Identify yourself, you bastard! Let me fucking kill you!"

Everybody there started cursing out loud. To nobody's surprise, Tian Yanyu's accidental outburst had caused a huge commotion.

'Shit...' Tian Yanyu began sweating profusely when everybody there learned that it was her who screamed and disturbed their peace, their gazes so sharp it could kill.

"You idiot...!" Tian Suyin was shaking her head while rubbing her eyes at Tian Yanyu, as she instantly understood the gravity of the situation.

Tian Yanyu's actions had led to everyone there losing their focus with some even losing their chance to receive enlightenment from the stone statue, costing them 7 years of time, which is akin to disturbing someone while they were on the verge of a breakthrough, considered as one of the biggest taboo within the cultivation world.

"Sect Leader Yu Jian! This is the second time your Jade Sword Manor has caused trouble for everyone here! We'll have to ask your sect to leave immediately!" The Blue Swallow Sword Sect and the Lightning Sword Academy began pressuring Yu Jian and his sect to leave.

However, some people there were not satisfied with just this punishment, especially those that had their enlightenment interrupted.

"That bitch who just shouted needs to be punished separately! She nearly crippled some of us just now, so it would only be fair if we did the same to her!"

"Yeah! Cripple her cultivation!"

Tian Yanyu turned to look at Yuan, her only hope, with despair on her face.

Yuan sighed, "It hasn't even been half a day since I entered the tomb and I've already encountered two incidents... The future's looking bleak..."

Sometime later, Yuan's voice boomed, "Everyone, please calm down!"

He mixed his spiritual energy in the voice, causing it to ring in everyone's head, making it impossible to ignore or miss.

The chaos halted for a moment as everyone there shifted their gaze from Tian Yanyu to Yuan.

"I would like to apologize on behalf of my friend, as I am somewhat responsible for her outburst. I also understand your anger and frustration, so I am willing to teach everyone here the complete technique of this stone statue as compensation. What do you say?"

Yuan's words kept the place dead silent for many moments, as nobody there dared to believe their ears just now.

In order to have the complete technique of the Nameless Stone Warrior, one must have fully comprehended it, something that hasn't been done since its discovery 1,000 years ago, so it was natural for the people there to doubt Yuan's words.

Knowing this, Yuan acted swiftly and retrieved his sword. Then, he began moving according to the movements he'd comprehended from the Nameless Stone Warrior in front of his audience, leaving everyone there speechless.

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Chapter 1117 Moon Splitting Sword Art

After performing the Moon Splitting Sword Art flawlessly in front of everyone there, Yuan stopped and patiently waited for their response.

"Y-You can't be serious... Did he really comprehend the technique from the Nameless Stone Warrior...?"

"I comprehended about 30 percent of the technique, and from my understanding, his earlier movements matched the technique perfectly, not to mention how flawlessly and fluidly they flowed afterward."

Although nobody there could confirm whether Yuan had truly performed the real technique from the Nameless Stone Warrior, nobody there doubted him, as his performance was just that perfect and convincing.

"Moon Splitting Sword Art." Yuan spoke in a calm voice that sounded as clear as thunder.

"That is the name of the technique left behind by this Nameless Stone Warrior. It is a Divine-rank technique."

Countless eyes widened with shock after learning about the technique's rank. Forget about Divine-rank techniques, even Heaven-rank techniques are still considered very valuable in the Third Heaven, so only top sects and families like the Seven Legacy Families would have Divine-rank techniques, yet Yuan was willing to teach everyone there such a valuable technique as compensation? It was almost too good to be true.

'This must be what they call a blessing in disguise...' Those that had their enlightenment interrupted by Tian Yanyu and nearly became crippled no longer blamed Tian Yanyu. In fact, they even praised her for giving them this opportunity.

Yuan's voice resounded again a moment later, "I will display this technique two more times for a total of three times. Whether you can learn it or not is entirely up to you. If you have any problem with my friend's mistake just now after I share this technique, I will have other ways of dealing with it. Do I make myself clear?"

Although Yuan's voice sounded calm and gentle, it was actually filled with hidden killing intent.

"This bastard... Now that I look at him closely, he's a peak Spirit King! Is his young appearance just a disguise, or is he truly that talented?"

"Makes sense, considering that he'd managed to comprehend this Nameless Stone Warrior when nobody else could for over 1,000 years."

Yuan started executing the Moon Splitting Sword Art for the second time a few moments later. When that happened, all of the cultivators there sealed their mouths, cleared their mind, widened their eyes, and even refused to blink to make sure they didn't miss a single detail.

Once he finished performing the Moon Splitting Sword Art, Yuan proceeded to stand there for half an hour without moving a muscle, allowing the cultivators there to do their thing.

"Are you sure you should be doing this, Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang asked him while they waited.

"What's the problem?"

"Well... First of all, you're giving away a high-grade Divine-rank technique for free... Even worse, most if not all of them are not qualified to even learn this technique. What if the Legacy Tomb decides to punish you?" Feng Yuxiang expressed her worries.

Yuan smiled, "What's wrong with sharing something that is mine to begin with? It's just a Divine-rank technique. Also, I truly feel guilty for what happened to them today, not to mention the disciples that I nearly killed by accident. And as I'd already said, even if I show them this technique, it's not like all of them are capable of actually learning it."

Once 30 minutes had passed, Yuan lifted his sword into the air again and began performing the technique for the third and final time.

The area became even more silent as the cultivators there tried their best to burn the sword technique into their memories.

At the end, Yuan said to them, "Now, if you still have any problems with my friend, raise your hand."

"..."

Nobody there dared to move a single muscle.

"Good. Then I hope you'll all gain something from this sword technique."

Even though everyone there has memorized the technique movements, they were still required to actually understand and perform the technique by themselves. This could take months, even years, but only time will tell.

However, there was a method that could bypass this, and that is to have someone who already fully comprehends the technique to transfer their knowledge and understanding to another person, allowing them to essentially skip the majority of the process.

"Give me your forehead." Yuan said to Tian Yanyu after returning to her side.

Tian Yanyu didn't question him and leaned forward.

Yuan poked her head, transferring the entire Moon Splitting Sword Art manual as well as his understanding for the technique into her head.

"T-This is..."

Tian Yanyu was shocked by what Yuan had just done.

"I-I don't know what else to say besides thank you..." She muttered in a low voice.

Yuan smiled, "Go ahead and try it."

Tian Yanyu nodded and immediately retrieved her sword. She closed her eyes and began moving her body a moment later, performing the Moon Splitting Sword Art with seemingly no effort.

When the others saw what had happened, they immediately became envious of Tian Yanyu, who was receiving all of the special treatment.

'This lucky bitch gets to skip the most tedious part all because she has a powerful sugar daddy!'

'Damn it! Why don't I have a handsome young man spoon feeding me techniques as well?! Although I'm not as pretty as her, I am not that far behind!'

Yuan noticed Tian Suyin staring at him and smiled, "If you'd like, I can perform technique transfer for you as well."

Tian Suyin swallowed nervously. Although she was an immensely prideful individual, she couldn't pass up such an opportunity, as this would save her years of effort.

"I-If you don't mind..." She nodded with a somewhat rosy face.

After receiving the technique from Yuan through technique transfer, Tian Suyin entered a trance-like state as she was filled with awe after learning the complexity and prowess of the sword technique, which is now her strongest technique.

Tian Yanyu couldn't help but chuckle after seeing her mother in such a state.

Meanwhile, the others could only swallow their envy and try their best to understand the technique by themselves.

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Chapter 1118 A Treasure Has Appeared!

After learning the Moon Splitting Sword Art, both Tian Suyin and Tian Yanyu began performing the technique in front of the spectators there.

The two of them started at the same time while standing only a few meters away from each other. The spectators quickly noticed that their movements were perfectly in sync, almost as though their mind and body were linked to each other at this moment.

The daughter and mother pair danced side by side with a sword in their hand, mesmerizing the spectators. Not only was their sword technique awe-inspiring, the wielders were also fine beauties themselves.

But compared to when Yuan performed the technique, they were still lacking in many ways.

"As expected of a Divine-rank technique, what profound movements... Even with his assistance, it will take a few years for me to fully grasp this technique..." Tian Suyin released a deep sigh after she finished her sword dance.

She turned to look at Yuan with a perplexed expression on her face.

'Just what is his motive? Why is he helping us like this?' Tian Suyin just couldn't stop suspecting Yuan, who came out of the blue and started assisting their family with an obviously fake pretense.

As a cultivator who has experienced many hardships, she was the type to be skeptical about everything. However, Yuan's actions have left her utterly

speechless.

She thought at first that his goal was to impress her daughter, Tian Yanyu, but that possibly seemed to be less likely as she spent more time watching him, as he doesn't look at her with lust or anything similar.

'Furthermore, if he truly had ulterior motives, why is he going through so much effort to achieve it when he clearly has enough power to get whatever he wants? Maybe he's genuinely just trying to help us...?' Tian Suyin was beginning to get a headache just thinking about this matter, so she decided to stop for the time being and continue watching Yuan.

Once Tian Yanyu finished her sword dance, she withdrew her sword and turned to look at Yuan with a satisfied and bright smile on her pretty face.

"I really cannot thank you enough for this, Xiao Yang."

"What are you going to do now?" Yuan then asked.

"Well, we were planning to check out the other sites to see if we can comprehend those— at least until a treasure appears."

Every time the Nameless Emperor's Tomb opens, treasures would appear in random areas. This has been happening for so long that it makes one wonder if there's an unlimited amount of treasures within the tomb. And when a treasure appears, a war would break out between multiple factions.

"At least three treasures will appear every opening with nine treasures being the most that have appeared." Tian Yanyu explained.

"Is that so—"

Just as Yuan opened his mouth, someone there shouted, "A treasure has appeared!"

Everybody there turned to look at the person who just spoke while the Sect Leaders and Elders went to gather more information.

"Where is the treasure?!"

"When did it appear?!"

"What kind of treasure is it?!"

The man quickly answered their questions, "A sword treasure appeared near the Stone Sword Valley around 4 hours ago, and it's at least Divine-grade!"

"Divine-grade sword! This is going to cause a bloodbath, and it's even the very first treasure this year!" Tian Yanyu sucked in a cold breath of air after hearing this information.

"Let's go! We must get there before it's too late!"

The Sect Leader of the Blue Swallow Sword Sect shouted at his disciples, and without any hesitation, they all flew towards the south.

The Lightning Sword Academy quickly followed.

"Let's also go. Even though there's a good chance that we won't get it, we must try." Sect Leader Yu Jian said to his disciples.

"What are you going to do, Xiao Yang?" Tian Yanyu asked him.

"I will come along with you for this one."

"Great!"

Thus, Yuan followed the Jade Sword Manor to the Stone Sword Valley, which took them just a little under three days to arrive.

Once they arrived at the location, they could see thousands of cultivators that came before them crowding the place.

The Stone Sword Valley is a vast land that had countless stone swords of various sizes stabbed into the ground, making it seem as though it was a graveyard for swords.

And hovering a few hundred meters in the air within the Stone Sword Valley was a beautiful sword with a red blade.

However, this blade was protected by some kind of aura, making it impossible for anyone there to acquire it yet.

In the Nameless Emperor's Tomb, the saying 'first come first serve' doesn't exist. When a treasure appears, it will be in this unobtainable state for anywhere between three to seven days, allowing everyone the chance to acquire it, hence why the Jade Sword Manor and many other sects bothered to travel to this area despite the time it took them to arrive.

"What a beautiful sword..." Tian Yanyu mumbled in a dazed voice as her eyes were glued to the sword in the air.

"Do you want it?" Yuan asked with a mysterious smile on his face.

She turned to look at him with a smile, "You make it sound like it's an easy thing to do."

Yuan swept the entire place with his divine sense before speaking in a confident voice, "Well, nobody here can stop me if I want to get it."

"Are you serious...?" Tian Yanyu's eyes widened.

There were thousands of powerful cultivators there with multiple Spirit Kings. Even the Silent Rippers wouldn't be able to last a minute if they had to go against everyone there.

"I have no need for the sword, but if you want it, just say the word and I will get it for you."

"Okay..." Tian Yanyu nodded with a slightly rosy face.

"..." Tian Suyin's eyebrows twitched at their interaction, and she couldn't help but feel a little jealousy for her own daughter.

Chapter 1119 Fighting For The Treasure

"Sect Leaders and Family Heads, may I request for a brief meeting to talk about our situation before the treasure unseals itself?" A middle-aged man emanating a powerful aura at the peak Spirit King realm suddenly spoke in a loud and clear voice.

This man was Huang Lee, Sect Leader of a renowned Sect called the Seven Profound Swords, one of the top three Sects within the Third Heaven.

All of the Sect Leaders and Family Heads there gathered below the treasure shortly after.

"I will get straight to the point." Huang Lee spoke a moment later with a solemn expression on his face.

"This treasure will, without a doubt, cause a great deal of trouble for all of us, so I have a suggestion that will reduce the bloodshed. Each Sect and Family here will have three members randomly picked to fight for the treasure in a tournament-style manner. No matter if they are a Spirit Lord or Spirit King, Disciple or Elder, everyone will have a chance to be picked. What do you think? Although it has many flaws, it is better than a full out war this early in the tomb, am I right?"

"If you refuse to participate in this, those who have come to an agreement will work together to deal with them before getting the treasure. I already have Sect Leader Ming and Sect Leader Zhong's agreement, as well as the Li Family and Gu Family's agreement."

The Sect Leaders and Family Heads immediately began pondering.

Sect Leader Ming's sect is ranked 7 while Sect Leader Zhong's Sect is ranked 4th. The Li Family and the Gu Family are from the Seven Legacy Families. If we include Sect Leader Huang Lee's ranked 3rd sect, they had a very good chance of eliminating everyone there if they worked together.

When a treasure appears like this, it is very common for the people there to come up with different solutions to reduce the bloodshed, especially when many strong parties are involved.

After sharing their opinions with each other for several minutes, all of the Sect Leaders and Families there agreed to Huang Lee's suggestion.

"If you are a Rogue Cultivator, you may also participate in the tournament, but you are not allowed to work with other Rogue Cultivators. If you have any questions, you have five minutes to voice them." Huang Lee said as he glared at the Rogue Cultivators there with a disdainful look in his gaze.

The Rogue Cultivators there were not happy about Huang Lee's suggestion that was settled without even including them in the discussion, but there was nothing they could do, as they did not have the power to defy the rules set by those far stronger than them.

"I have a question. Are the chosen allowed to forfeit the match? I cannot imagine forcing a young disciple to fight any of the Seniors here." Yu Jian asked.

Huang Lee nodded, "Of course, you are allowed to forfeit, but you may only do so before you enter the stage. The matches will also be randomized so you won't know who your opponent is until you enter the stage. Furthermore, we are not allowed to pick the participants, so everyone that is present here can be chosen to fight, regardless if they are a disciple or sect leader. If you cannot accept this rule, you may sit out."

"What about those that arrive after the participants are chosen?" Another person asked.

"They won't be allowed to participate. If they dare to intervene, we will all work together to get rid of them."

Half an hour later, once all of the Sect Leaders and Family Heads spoke to their respective people, everyone there agreed to Huang Lee's suggestion.

"Then I will now begin the selection."

Huang Lee retrieved a talisman and showed it to everyone there, "This treasure will randomly pick three people within a certain group. I will allow any Sect Leader and Family Head to inspect this treasure beforehand to make sure there is no foul play here."

Yu Jian and others began taking their turn inspecting the talisman. When they found nothing wrong with it, Huang Lee began the selection process.

One by one, three individuals are picked from the sects and families there.

When an individual is picked, the talisman would shoot out a green beam of light that immediately envelopes the chosen.

Sometime later, it was the Jade Sword Manor's turn.

Everyone associated with the sect swallowed nervously as the talisman shot out its first beam of light.

A moment later, everyone there turned to look at the young woman who had just been chosen.

This young woman's face immediately paled when she realized that she was picked.

"G-Good luck, Senior Sister Wan..."

Disciple Wan Ying was a Core Disciple of the Jade Sword Manor, and she was a 7th level Spirit Lord.

Although she is considered a top talent in her sect, ranking top 5 amongst all Core Disciples, she was akin to an ant in this small tournament, where multiple Spirit King had been chosen to fight.

And before the Jade Sword Manor could even despair, the talisman already picked the second participant amongst their group.

"S-Sect Leader! It picked Sect Leader!"

The disciples rejoiced when Yu Jian had been chosen to participate.

However, Yu Jian himself did not celebrate, at least not until their third fighter was chosen.

A few seconds later, the talisman picked the third and final fighter from the Jade Sword Manor.

When the light was released by the talisman, Yuan followed the light with his gaze. Eventually, he turned his head to look at the beautiful young lady standing beside him with raised eyebrows.

Yu Jian could only sigh in silence after seeing the results.

"X-Xiao Yang... What should I do...?" Tian Yanyu looked at him with a terrified look on her face when she realized that she'd just been chosen. Despite being a Core Disciple, she wasn't any stronger than Wan Ying. In fact, she was amongst the weaker Core Disciples, as she'd only recently become one.

Chapter 1120 Fighting For The Treasure(2)

"Calm down, Yan'er." Tian Suyin said as she smacked her daughter's back.

"Calm down?! I have to fight Spirit Kings if I don't want to become a burden for the sect!" Tian Yanyu frowned.

"You don't have to participate if you don't want to. I won't force you to fight. It's also unreasonable to ask you to fight a Spirit King. We simply got unlucky." Yu Jian appeared and said to her, "Also, with how many powerhouses are present, I had no hopes to acquire the treasure since the beginning."

"They're right. You can simply forfeit the match." Yuan followed.

Once Tian Yanyu calmed down a little, she gritted her teeth and said, "If our opponents aren't at a level where I cannot handle, I will fight too. Although I do not qualify to participate in this event, I won't be a coward either."

Yu Jian smiled after hearing her words, "Good. Even though we have almost no chance of winning this, I still don't plan on going down without a fight. This is no longer just about the treasure. This is about keeping our sect's honor and reputation. We will fight those we can fight and back down if it's too risky."

When it was Huang Lee and the Seven Profound Swords turn for selection, the entire place became dead silent as everyone there nervously waited for the results.

A few moments later, three individuals were chosen.

"What?! All three of their fighters are Spirit Kings! They even have two peak Spirit Kings!"

"Fuck! I bet they cheated!"

"How is cheating even possible? Their talisman had been inspected by every Senior here."

Many people suspected that Huang Lee had cheated, but without any proof, nobody there dared to voice their complaints fearing retaliation.

All of the top sects and powerful families went last in the selection, and shockingly, all of them had insane luck with at least 2 Spirit Kings in their team.

It was clear to all of the small sects and families there that these powerful factions had worked together and manipulated the results somehow, giving themselves a massive advantage.

"Those shameless old bastards never intended on giving us a chance...!" Yu Jian gritted his teeth in anger after seeing the results.

"So we never stood a chance from the beginning, huh? Why am I not surprised?" Tian Yanyu sighed.

Pretty much everyone that wasn't part of the 'lucky group' silently cursed Huang Lee and the others for their shameless actions. However, there was nothing they could do about it. In the first place, they had no solid proof of foul play, and everything was circumstantial at best.

Even if they had proof that Huang Lee had cheated, who was bold enough to say it out loud? Who would dare to raise their voice against the top sects and the Seven Legacy Families? Nobody was foolish enough to throw away their life in such an unwinnable situation, so they could only suck it up and endure it for now.

"How despicable..." Tian Yanyu muttered in a mosquito-like voice.

"I can't say I'm surprised, though." Yuan was the only person there who could smile at this moment.

"I would expect this kind of tactic from other sects, but for the Seven Profound Swords and the Seven Legacy Families to do this... I'm speechless..." Tian Suyin sighed.

"They must really want the sword." Yuan continued to smile.

The selection eventually came to an end, and acting like he was innocent, Huang Lee immediately started the tournament.

"The two sects or families that will be fighting will also be randomized. The talisman will now choose two sects to fight." Huang Lee said as he poured some of his spiritual energy into the talisman, causing two beams of light to appear, picking two parties from the dozens of groups there.

"Once you step onto the stage, you can no longer forfeit, just like a real deathmatch. This is not like your usual playground. There is no room for mercy here. If you value your life, forfeit now." Huang Lee said to them.

"..."

The two parties stared at each other.

"I forfeit."

"Me too."

Both parties forfeited all three of their matches.

"What's the point of risking our lives when we don't even have a chance to acquire the treasure? Who's dumb enough to do that?"

Many people had this thought inside their mind.

Since Huang Lee and the top factions manipulated the whole thing, they no longer had any motivation to participate in the tournament for the treasure.

The next several matches also resulted in forfeits from both sides.

"How boring." Huang Lee sneered with an arrogant look on his face.

With everyone that doesn't have at least 2 Spirit Kings in their team forfeiting, the tournament progressed with barely any pauses.

Eventually, it was the Jade Sword Manor's turn to enter the stage.

"Our opponents also have two Spirit Lords and one Spirit King. Do you two want to fight despite knowing that it is a pointless fight?" Yu Jian asked Tian Yanyu and Wan Ying.

"I want to fight..." Wan Ying said with a resolute expression on her face.

"Even if you might be paired up with the Spirit King and die? Even if your efforts won't be rewarded?" Yu Jian asked.

Wan Ying nodded.

"What about you, Disciple Tian?" Yu Jian shifted his attention to her.

"It's going to be a difficult fight for you even if you aren't paired with the Spirit King. Nobody will blame you for forfeiting."

"..." Tian Yanyu remained silent.

She wanted to try out her new sword technique, but she wasn't prepared to risk her life over something like this. However, she also couldn't refuse, as she didn't want to feel like a coward.

"If you want to fight, go ahead." Yuan suddenly said to her.

"Huh?" Tian Yanyu looked at him with a puzzled face.

"Y-You! Are you telling my daughter to die?!" Tian Suyin immediately began fuming.

"Relax. As long as I am here, nobody can kill her." Yuan smiled.

He turned to look at Tian Yanyu and continued, "Don't you want to see how powerful your new technique is?"

"I do..." She nodded in a dazed manner.

"Then do it. I will protect you no matter what, I promise."

After her recent experience with Yuan, Tian Yanyu had gained blind faith in him, so she didn't even question how he was going to protect her before so many experts.

"Alright, I will fight." She said in a resolute voice the following moment.

"Are you serious?! How can you believe him so easily?!" Tian Suyin was still doubtful.

"Because he promised." Tian Yanyu responded with an innocent smile, leaving her speechless.

And before Tian Suyin could say anything else, Tian Yanyu approached the stage.

"I'm sorry..." Yu Jian said to Tian Suyin before going after Tian Yanyu.

"If my daughter dies here because of you, I swear I will kill you with my own hands..." Tian Suyin glared at Yuan.

"And I won't resist if that really happens." Yuan said with a confident expression on his face.

"..."

"Do you plan on acquiring that sword for her, Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang suddenly asked him in a curious voice.

"It would pair up nicely with her new technique, don't you think so?" Yuan chuckled.

"You're spoiling her too much... I'm a little envious." Feng Yuxiang could only shake her head inwardly.

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Chapter 1121 Fighting For The Treasure(3)

Once the Jade Sword Manor and their opponents entered the fighting arena, Huang Lee enclosed them in a separate concealment formation so that they couldn't see anything.

Shortly after they entered the formation, Huang Lee's talisman released a beam of light that shone into the formation, enveloping whoever it was pointing at with a slight glow. However, nobody but the three people inside the formation knew who was chosen.

"You have 10 seconds to decide whether you want to fight or forfeit. Remember, you will forfeit your chance to surrender once you exit the formation and enter the stage." Huang Lee's voice resounded in their ears.

"Sect Leader, I will fight." Disciple Wan Ying said with a resolute expression on her face as her body was enveloped in a faint light.

Yu Jian nodded his head with a serious face, "Good luck."

"I will be back soon." After bowing to him, Disciple Wan Ying left the formation and came face to face with her opponent.

"Thank the Heavens my opponent is not their Spirit King..." Disciple Wan Ying sighed in relief inwardly after seeing her opponent, who was only a single level above her.

Her opponent also did the same.

"As you've already seen many times by now, the fight will begin when the talisman activates, and it will not end until there is only one of you left

standing." Huang Lee said to them in a nonchalance voice, almost as though he couldn't care less about their insignificant life.

The two fighters took a moment to prepare themselves.

A few seconds later, the talisman hovering above the arena suddenly shone brightly, signaling the start of the fight.

Whoosh!

Both fighters immediately rushed at each other while using their respective techniques.

Their swords and spiritual energy clashed, causing a powerful ripple to sweep the place.

The two of them would go back and forth for many minutes with neither of them slowing down.

Once Disciple Wan Ying eventually started getting pushed back, she quickly retrieved a pill and tossed it inside her mouth.

Under normal circumstances, the use of pills and treasures during a one-on-one match would be strictly forbidden, but their situation was a bit special. Even though they were in a tournament-style match, there were almost no rules, almost as though they were following the rules of the jungle, where one can use whatever advantage they have to win their fight or die trying.

When Disciple Wan Ying's opponent saw her actions, he also started consuming pills.

Since they were able to consume pills to restore their strength, the two of them would continue to go all out, unleashing all of their strength to suppress each other without holding back, almost like two sprinters near the end of a race.

After five whole minutes of fighting, Disciple Wan Ying managed to catch her opponent off guard, sending him to the afterlife with a quick slash in the neck.

Disciple Wan Ying took a deep breath before walking off the platform and returning to the concealment formation without even trying to celebrate her narrow victory.

When Yu Jian and Tian Yanyu saw Disciple Wan returning, their lips immediately curved into a smile.

"You did it!" Tian Yanyu was ecstatic to see that her fellow disciple had survived.

"Great job, Disciple Wan." Yu Jian nodded in acknowledgement.

However, before she could even say anything, the talisman activated again, picking the second fighter.

"..."

Yu Jian and Wan Ying turned to look at Tian Yanyu, who was now being enveloped by a light.

"You don't have to fight. There's a fifty-fifty chance that you'll have to fight their Spirit King. It's too risky." Yu Jian sighed out loud.

But to his surprise, Tian Yanyu shook her head and said, "No matter who may be my opponent, I still want to fight."

"Why would you do something so brave yet foolish? Unlike Disciple Wan, you only recently became a Core Disciple. You will have a hard time defeating their Spirit Lord, much less their Spirit King." Yu Jian frowned.

Tian Yanyu responded with a gentle smile on her face, "Because nothing will happen to me. He promised."

And without waiting for a response, as her time limit was reaching its end, Tian Yanyu stepped outside of the formation to face her opponent.

"..."

Tian Yanyu's eyebrows twitched when she saw a middle-aged man standing on the opposite side of the stage, and he was emanating the aura of a peak Spirit King!

'Looks like I had picked the short end of the straw...' She sighed inwardly.

"That idiot!" Tian Suyin cursed in a low voice when she saw her own daughter entering the stage. "Why didn't she just forfeit?!"

"Don't expect me to go easy on you just because you're a junior." The Spirit King on the stage said as he glared at Tian Yanyu.

"I wasn't counting on you to, anyway." After putting on a brave expression, Tian Yanyu retrieved her sword.

'I only have one chance to defeat him... At the beginning of the fight when he least expects it!' She had already planned on going all out straight from the beginning. After all, she wouldn't even last a minute against a peak Spirit King.

The moment the talisman shone, Tian Yanyu used her movement technique to close their distance before activating her new technique, Moon Splitting Sword Art.

Perhaps it was due to his arrogance, but the Spirit King didn't move and only quietly watched as Tian Yanyu unleashed her technique.

"!!!"

The Spirit King's eyes widened with surprise when a semi-transparent moon suddenly appeared behind Tian Yanyu.

The disciples from the Jade Sword Manor immediately recognized this technique, as they were mesmerized by its beauty not too long ago.

"A Divine-rank technique!"

A handful of people there exclaimed when they sensed the aura the technique emitted, their faces filled with surprise. After all, it was

incredibly rare for people outside the Seven Legacy Families and the top sects to techniques above Heaven-rank.

Whoosh!

Tian Yanyu quickly swung her sword at her opponent, who was taken by surprise for a split second because of her technique.

Her blade managed to reach the Spirit King's body, but it could only leave behind a small cut before the Spirit King evaded the rest of her blade.

The Spirit King looked at the cut on his arm and trembled in anger.

"A mere Spirit Lord... I'll fucking kill you!"

The Spirit King exploded with spiritual energy and killing intent, causing Tian Yanyu to feel as though she was being choked by the throat.

"DIE!"

The Spirit King swung his weapon, sending a massive arc of energy at Tian Yanyu, who couldn't even attempt to dodge it due to the pressure from it.

'Xiao Yang...!' She cried inwardly.

Whoosh!

A figure suddenly flew onto the stage and stood in front of Tian Yanyu.

This shocked everyone there, not because he intervened in the match, but because they were unable to follow this person's movement at all.

After appearing on the stage, Yuan causally waved his hand at the incoming blade of energy, destroying it the moment his skin touched it, almost as though the blade of energy was nothing more than empty air.

"What?!" The Spirit King exclaimed in a shocked voice after witnessing this, even feeling a little scared.

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Chapter 1122 Fighting For The Treasure(4)

'Did he just stop my technique at full power with his bare hands?! Impossible! I must have seen it wrong!' The Spirit King convinced himself that he was just mistaken, as that was the simpler route.

"Who are you? How dare you interrupt our match?" The Spirit King asked with a wary face.

"Hmph!" A cold snort suddenly resounded, and a figure descended on the stage, standing between Yuan and the Spirit King.

"I don't care who you are, how dare you so brazenly interfere when I have made it very clear that no interference is allowed regardless of the reason! I hope you are prepared to take responsibility for your foolish decision." Huang Lee glared at Yuan like an eagle at a weak prey.

Yuan calmly smiled before responding, "And why would you assume that everyone here will obey your unreasonable request?"

"You, a mere junior, dare talk back to me?! Have you lost your mind? Do you even know who I am?!" Huang Lee's eyes flared up with anger.

"I don't know, nor do I care. Anyways, why don't we stop this obviously manipulated game? It's clear to everyone here that you had manipulated the whole thing to give yourself— as well as those that planned this with you an advantage over the others. What you're doing here is no different than bullying the weak."

"How dare you accuse the Sect Leader of manipulation!" Someone there suddenly shouted.

"Are you also claiming that the Seven Legacy Families here are bullying the weak?!" Someone from one of the families shouted.

"How interesting. Do you have any evidence to back up your preposterous claims?"

Another figure descended on the stage as he asked Yuan.

This individual was Li Mao, a high-ranking elder of the Li Family, one of Seven Legacy Families.

"What if I don't?" Yuan narrowed his eyes in a challenging manner.

"Then I will kill you on the spot for uttering nonsense and trying to ruin our reputations." Li Mao glared at him.

Yuan smiled, "You're going to kill me for interfering with the match anyway."

"Damn right."

Huang Lee muttered right as he appeared beside Yuan while swinging down his sword.

Without moving for his spot, Yuan lifted his arm in a casual manner, and he would catch the incoming sword with nothing but two fingers the following moment.

"Wha—?!"

This shocked everyone there, especially Huang Lee.

Even though he didn't exert all of his strength, it was still strong enough to kill anyone below the fifth level of Spirit King with ease, yet some unknown junior had managed to catch it with his bare hands.

Yuan turned to look at the shocked Huang Lee and spoke in a nonchalant voice, "Unlike you, I don't want unnecessary bloodshed, so I will give you a chance to back down before things get—"

However, before Yuan could even finish his sentence, another sword was already flying at him from his blind spot.

Yuan knew about the second attack, but he didn't do anything about it and allowed this person to slice his neck.

"My heavens..."

The person who attempted to sneak attack Yuan was left speechless when his sword was stopped at his target's neck, but there didn't appear to be anything blocking the sword.

Yuan, still with a sword pressing against his neck, turned to look at Li Mao's terrified face and spoke, "I hope you understand the difference in our strength and not do anything—"

Once again, before he could finish his sentence, another figure descended upon him.

This time, it was a middle-aged man wearing the Gu Family's uniform, and he was also using a sword technique.

"Roaring Blade!"

The strength of a peak Spirit King using a Heaven-rank sword technique descended upon Yuan's defenseless figure.

"At least let me finish my sentences."

Yuan's eyes suddenly flickered golden for half a second before returning to normal.

Thud!

The middle-aged man suddenly stopped his attack mid-air and collapsed on the floor while his sword bounced away.

Seeing this, both Huang Lee and Li Mao instinctively jumped back, landing beside the unconscious body on the stage.

"W-What did you just do to him?!" Huang Lee roared at Yuan.

"He must have used a spiritual technique!" Li Mao gritted his teeth.

"Don't worry, he's not dead— at least not yet." Yuan said.

"Since you care so much about this event, let's do it like this instead. Starting from now, anyone here can challenge me to a match, and if they win, they will get to take the treasure above. If nobody can defeat me before the treasure is unsealed, I will take it for myself. Of course, to make this fair, I will allow you to team up. I won't mind even if everyone here attacks me at once."

"However..."

After a brief pause, an immense pressure that trampled on the people and their spirits appeared out of thin air.

"If you decide to fight me, you will forfeit your life. You have been warned."

The entire place fell silent with the only thing that could be heard being the sound of their own hearts beating anxiously.

"W-Who are you?" Huang Lee muttered in a low voice after a long moment of silence.

Yuan couldn't help but show a mocking smile, "I thought you didn't care about my identity?"

Huang Lee gritted his teeth. He's never felt such humiliation before.

"How dare you mock me?! DIE!!!"

Huang Lee swung his sword at Yuan with a Divine-rank technique.

"Profound Sword Art— Final Strike!"

The sword flying towards Yuan had overwhelming pressure that could be felt even miles away.

Yuan could only sigh inwardly as he retrieved his Empyrean Overlord before swinging back.

The following moment, everyone there watched with wide eyes as Huang Lee's body was sent flying off the stage and into the crowd.

Cough

Huang Lee coughed up a mouthful of blood as he stared at Yuan with a look of disbelief on his face.

"What are you all waiting for?! Attack him!" He snapped at his own disciples, who hesitated to attack.

After all, what can they do when even their own sect leader couldn't win?

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Chapter 1123 Fighting For The Treasure(5)

"A-Attack!" The Elders eventually snapped out of it and shouted before rushing at Yuan.

When the disciples saw the Elders moving, they had no choice but to follow.

Thus, everyone from the Seven Profound Swords began attacking Yuan, who merely shook his head in silence.

[God of War's Astral Art]

A large figure wielding a massive blade appeared behind Yuan, and despite it being larger than before, it wasn't even at half of its full strength.

"W-What kind of technique is that?!" The disciples screamed in horror as they hastily halted their movements.

However, they were already in attack range, so all Yuan had to do was swing his sword.

"Don't say I didn't warn you!" Yuan exclaimed as he swung his sword.

A powerful force that seemed to be strong enough to sweep away even mountains clashed against the disciples, and without any resistance, the Seven Profound Swords' disciples were sent flying like swatted flies.

In a single attack, over half of their disciples were gone.

This shook the cores of those watching.

Yuan turned to look at his avatar and mumbled, "Even 20 percent is still a little too strong, huh..."

His soul strength has grown so much in such a short amount of time that he was having trouble controlling it.

After devastating the Seven Profound Swords, Yuan spoke again, "If you wish to continue, attack me again. However, I will make sure that none of you survive the next strike."

The disciples that survived the attack trembled on the spot, and their already lacking motivation disappeared completely.

The Elders from the Li Family and the Gu Family exchanged glances with each other.

After a moment of silence, they approached Yuan and gave him a courteous bow.

"Junior, do you happen to be someone from 'up there'?" The Li Family's elder asked him with a nervous face.

Yuan smiled inwardly when he realized that they had mistaken him as someone who came from the upper heavens under the Celestial Emperor's request.

Though, one cannot blame them for making this mistake, as it would only make sense for someone as young as Yuan to utterly destroy the Seven Profound Swords without any effort.

"What are you going to do if I am from 'up there'?" Yuan asked them without the slightest change to his expression.

"Forgive us for not recognizing your identity sooner, Young Master. The Gu Family will no longer participate in this event. If you wish, we can even assist you in securing the treasure." The Gu Family's Elder bowed to him again.

"You think the Young Master needs your help? What an unnecessary offer. He can secure the treasure by himself." The Li Family's Elder sneered.

The Gu Family's Elder gritted his teeth after hearing such words. The two families were never on good terms in the beginning, so this kind of bickering happens often.

Meanwhile, the other people there were amazed to see how quickly the Li Family and Gu Family changed their attitude.

"Just what is that person's identity for the Seven Legacy Families to be so respectful towards him?"

"Does 'up there' mean he's from the upper heavens? Why would someone like that be down here?"

"Although it's not common nowadays, people from the upper heavens used to come down here regularly solely to explore the Nameless Emperor's Tomb."

"Look at his uniform. Isn't that the Jade Sword Manor's uniform for esteemed guests?"

Tian Yanyu and Tian Suyin were left speechless after hearing the peoples' conversation. They had their suspicions that Yuan was someone from the upper heavens due to his unfathomable talent and strength, but this only made things more confusing for them.

Why would someone from the upper heavens help them to such an extent? Does his ancestor really owe their ancestor a debt, or is he helping them for a different reason?

'Regardless of his reasons, I'm glad he's on our side...' Tian Yanyu sighed inwardly, as she cannot imagine having someone like Yuan as an enemy.

When the Li Family and the Gu Family stepped back, nobody else dared to approach Yuan. As for Huang Lee, who'd barely managed to survive the attack, snuck away with his disciples in the midst of the commotion.

While he waited for the treasure to unseal itself, Yuan sat on the stage and closed his eyes.

"He's cultivating out in the open like this? Is he bold or insane? Even if he's powerful, to act so defenseless before so many people... What a mad lad."

"Arrogant bastard..."

Despite Yuan cultivating out in the open, nobody there actually dared to attack him.

About two hours later, news of another treasure appearing not far away began spreading, and those at Yuan's location immediately scrambled to the new location for obvious reasons.

Shortly after the news reached their location, everyone including the Jade Sword Manor left the scene, leaving Yuan alone with the treasure, which is unheard of within the Nameless Emperor's Tomb.

"Why didn't you leave with your sect?" Yuan stopped his cultivation to ask Tian Yanyu, who'd stayed behind even after her sect left to fight for the next treasure.

"I just didn't want to leave you alone." She calmly said.

"How about you?" Yuan turned to look at Tian Suyin, who also stayed behind for whatever reason.

"You think I'm going to leave my daughter alone with someone as suspicious as you?" She sneered.

Yuan merely smiled at her remarks.

"By the way, can I ask you a question?" Tian Yanyu suddenly asked.

"Sure."

"Are you really from... 'up there'?" She asked him with a somewhat nervous expression.

"You mean the upper heavens? Nope."

"What?! But you..."

"I know. I lied." He shrugged.

Tian Yanyu was speechless.

"I'm glad they didn't question you further..."

Suddenly, the treasure in the air began pulsating with powerful ripples.

"Does this mean it's unsealing?" Yuan asked.

"Yes."

The very next moment, the barrier protecting the sword shattered, and the sword began descending towards the ground.

However, Yuan didn't move even after the sword was lying on the ground.

"What are you waiting for?" Tian Suyin asked him with raised eyebrows.

"I have no use for it. You can have it," he calmly said, causing her eyes to widen with shock.

Chapter 1124 Nine Swords Trial

"S-Surely, you're jesting with us..." Tian Yanyu mumbled in a trembling voice.

"No, not at all. Take it. I have no need for a Divine-grade sword since I already have a much better one." Yuan calmly shook his head.

"..."

After a moment of silence, Tian Suyin spoke with a deep frown on her face, "Okay, what do you want from us?"

"What do you mean?"

"Are you telling me that you're going to hand over a Divine-grade treasure for free? I don't believe it. Sounds too good to be true."

Yuan shrugged, "Then I will leave it there and whoever is lucky enough will get it."

When she heard such words, Tian Suyin immediately rushed to pick up the sword before throwing it into her spatial ring.

"I guess I'm the fortunate one," she said with a stiff expression.

"Mother..." Tian Yanyu was left speechless by her actions.

"What are you looking at? He's the one who said he'd leave it there for anyone to pick up."

"Since you want it that badly, you can have it." Yuan smiled.

Tian Suyin cleared her throat but didn't say anything.

'I'm glad I stayed behind...' she smiled inwardly.

"What are you going to do now?" Tian Yanyu asked him. "Are you going to participate in the next treasure hunt as well?"

"No, I came here mostly just to make sure you were fine. Now that's done, I think I am going to do some exploring myself."

"I see..."

Tian Yanyu pondered for a brief second before opening her mouth again, "Do you mind if I followed you for a little?"

"Yanyu! You don't even know what kind of dangerous place he's going to! You're just going to be a burden!" Tian Suyin quickly rejected her request.

"I know, which is why I will only follow him until he leaves the outer area."

The Nameless Emperor's Tomb is split into three sections by the people; the outer area where it's the least dangerous; the inner area where only geniuses dare to enter; last but not least, the core area, a hellish area where most people that enter will never return.

"If it's just the outer area..." Tian Suyin felt a little more at ease after hearing this.

Furthermore, she wasn't completely opposed to following Yuan, as he was definitely powerful enough to protect them— even doing a much better job than the entirety of the Jade Sword Manor by himself.

Yuan began wandering the Nameless Emperor's Tomb shortly after while Tian Yanyu and Tian Suyin followed him from behind.

"There are actually a few places that I want to visit. In no particular order, the Sword Temple, Nine Swords Trial, and the Sword Pagoda." Yuan mumbled out loud as they moved.

"I've been to the Sword Pagoda once, but I was only able to make it to the third floor before getting kicked out." Tian Suyin sighed as she recalled her memories.

"What's the Sword Pagoda, again? I know I heard it before." Tian Yanyu asked.

"The Sword Pagoda is a place where you must climb seven floors by defeating the opponent on each floor. The higher floor you reach, the greater the reward. However, this place is immensely difficult. The highest anyone has ever climbed is only 5 floors."

"You managed to reach the third floor, right? What kind of treasure did you acquire?" Yuan asked out of curiosity.

"My cultivation increased by three levels in an instant, and I received a Heaven-rank movement technique."

"What?! One can increase their cultivation by three levels after clearing just a single floor?! That alone is already super good, not to mention the Heaven-rank technique!" Tian Yanyu was brimming with excitement.

"Perhaps, but 70 percent of participants cannot even pass the first floor, much less the second floor. About 10 percent of all participants can clear the second floor, but less than one percent will be able to clear the third. As for the fourth and fifth floor, less than 10 people have made it there."

"What kind of enemies did you fight?" Tian Yanyu continued to ask.

"A masked cultivator."

"Like the Nameless Emperor?" Yuan raised an eyebrow.

"No, they didn't have the same aura as the Nameless Emperor. Also, the masks they wore were different. You'll understand what I mean once you go there and face them yourself."

Yuan nodded.

The Nine Swords Trial was the nearest to their current location, so Yuan decided to go there first.

After three days of traveling nonstop, they finally arrived at their destination.

"So this is the Nine Swords Trial, huh..." Yuan mumbled as he stared at the large platform in the distance.

This platform was not as large as one would expect. It was about 5 meters in length and diameter, and there was a large statue standing not far away from it.

This statue was of a man wearing a mask, and he was holding the handle of a sword with both hands in front of him with the blade of the sword pointing directly horizontally at the sky.

Currently, this platform was surrounded by at least a hundred people, and there was even a single person standing on the platform.

However, the person standing on the platform appeared to be in dismay. His body was dripping with blood, and his expression looked as though he was on the verge of collapsing, but his gaze remained fixated at the statue before him.

The next moment, Yuan watched as an illusionary blade appeared in the sky before descending upon the man on the platform.

BOOM!

The attack caused the surrounding land to tremble while the people around the platform were pushed back by the force.

Once the dust settled, one could see that the man on the platform had been cleanly sliced in half.

However, nobody there seemed to be surprised, almost as though it was a common sight.

A few more moments later, the corpse and blood on the platform vaporized into the air, leaving not even a trace behind.

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Chapter 1125 Nine Swords Trial(2)

"How gruesome..." Tian Yanyu mumbled in a low voice after seeing what had happened to the man on the platform.

"Do you have any experience at this place, Senior?" Yuan suddenly asked.

"Does it look like I have a death wish? This place has one of the highest death rates in the outer area. No matter how good the reward is, it's simply too risky for me."

"Let's get a closer look." Yuan approached the crowd.

"I told him that he was biting more than he could chew. He should've stopped after enduring the third strike."

Yuan listened to the conversations being held by the people there.

"What a waste of talent."

"He was a disciple from the Thousand Saber Manor, right?"

"Yeah, he was one of their top 10 disciples, too."

"What a pity."

"A pity indeed."

By the time Yuan arrived at the platform, another individual was already on the platform and preparing for the trial.

"There will be a total of nine strikes."

A familiar voice suddenly resounded in the area.

Yuan turned to look at the statue, where the voice was echoing from.

"The more strikes you survive, the better the rewards. Once the sword appears, it will not disappear until it strikes the platform. You may step out of the platform at any time."

"The first sword will descend in five... four... three..."

When the voice counted down to zero, a massive sword appeared in front of the statue and slashed at the individual on the platform.

This sword bore immense pressure that could split even a mountain.

The man on the platform was at the 5th level of Spirit King, yet he could barely keep his eyes open before the pressure.

BOOM!

The ground shook once again as the massive sword struck the platform.

Once the dust settled, the people could see that the man had survived the strike, but his arms were already bleeding.

"The second sword will descend within five..."

Five seconds later, another sword appeared, and it was clearly a size larger than the previous.

"The second strike is about 1.5 times stronger than the first." Tian Suyin mumbled as the sword descended on the man for the second time.

BOOM!

The ground shook slightly harder this time.

When the spectators could see the man again, it was clear to them that he was already at his limit, as both of his arms were broken with the bones

sticking out and all.

"The third sword will descend within—"

Before the voice could even finish his sentence, the man jumped off the stage.

The following moment, orbs of light would emerge from the statue, entering the man who had just endured two strikes.

The man's aura immediately spiked as his cultivation rapidly strengthened, reaching the 7th level Spirit King in the time it took to take a deep breath. Furthermore, his injuries were completely healed.

"Heavens... his cultivation increased by two levels just like that? Since when did cultivation become so easy?" Tian Yanyu mumbled in a dazed voice.

"If you think it's so easy, why don't you get on the stage and try it yourself?" Tian Suyin sneered at her ignorant remarks.

"I-I will watch for a little longer..." She quickly responded.

Yuan agreed with her and proceeded to watch several more people challenge the Nine Swords Trial.

"So the strength of each strike differs from person to person... As expected, this place tests one's potential, not their achievements." He mumbled in a low voice.

In the end, out of 15 participants, two people had managed to endure 2 strikes, four people endured 1 strike, and the other nine people died from the first strike.

"Are you going to participate?" Yuan turned to look at Tian Yanyu.

"Can you guarantee that I won't die?" She asked in response.

"I can't." Yuan answered without hesitation.

"Then I won't. As enticing as the reward is, this is a little too risky even for me, especially when the trial is different for everyone. What about you? You're going to participate, right?"

He nodded, "Yes, I am going to participate."

"Good luck." Tian Yanyu didn't bother saying any unnecessary words since she knew that it would only be a waste of breath.

She trusted Yuan and his strength and that was all it mattered.

After waiting for several more people to go, Yuan finally decided to enter the stage.

'Even though my cultivation won't increase from this, my instincts tell me that there's something more important than that here.'

Yuan took a deep breath before retrieving the Empyrean Overlord.

"The first sword will descend in five... four... three..."

"Two... one..."

A sword appeared before Yuan, but there was something different about this sword.

Compared to the swords that appeared previously, this sword was not semi-transparent and was completely solid, just like a real sword.

Moreover, the size of this sword was shockingly large— so massive that it was several times bigger than the statue itself.

"Heavens! What's with the size of that sword?! It's just his first strike, yet it's already bigger than the fourth strike for that Thousand Saber Manor's disciple!"

"Is there something wrong with the trial, or is there something special about that young man?!"

"I have witnessed every trial here for the last 100 years, but I have never seen anything like this before!"

"R-Run! Heaven knows how destructive it will be! We'll all get caught up in it at this rate!" Someone there suddenly shouted.

Upon hearing such words, everyone there immediately began scrambling away, running as far away as they could before the sword descended.

Meanwhile, Yuan stood as still as a statue on the platform with a resolute expression on his face.

The sword began descending towards Yuan the following second, creating a force so powerful that it split all of the nearby clouds halfway before impact, creating a clear blue sky in an instant.

Despite the immense pressure bearing down on him, Yuan swung the Empyrean Overlord at the sword in the sky with seemingly no effort at all, and there was even a slight smile on his face.

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Chapter 1126 Nine Swords Trial(3)

The moment Yuan's Empyrean Overlord clashed with the first sword, an intense ripple swept the area while lifting a layer of the ground into the air.

When the spectators saw this, they sighed in relief knowing that they'd made the right decision by distancing themselves from the platform.

Once the dust settled and the spectators could finally see the situation on the platform, they were surprised to see an uninjured figure standing there.

"H-He actually managed to survive that?"

"And he doesn't even seem a bit fazed! What a monster!"

Before the spectators could even fully grasp the situation, the second sword appeared, and it was almost two times bigger than the first sword.

This stunned the spectators. If the second sword is already this massive, would the later swords fill the entire sky?

A few seconds later, the second sword descended from the sky, creating an even stronger ripple.

BOOM!

The entire ground shook and everyone could feel themselves being lifted off the ground for a brief second.

"Good lord! The sword may be twice as big, but the strength is at least three times stronger than the previous sword!"

"And this is only the strength of the second sword?! There's no way he's going to survive the next one!"

After blocking the second strike, Yuan could feel a slight tingly sensation in his hands, but such a thing can be neglected completely.

'The second strike is already this powerful... What's the ninth strike going to be like?' Yuan couldn't help but wonder to himself.

"The third strike will descend within 5... 4... 3..."

Yuan quickly cleared his mind and focused on the situation at hand.

"Hah!"

Yuan swung the Empyrean Overlord upwards, clashing with the colossal sword in the sky.

CLANG!

The spectators that believed they were in a safe distance were quickly swept up by the force and sent tumbling even further away.

By now, the entire platform was shattered, and there were fissures all around the area, looking as though a war had taken place there.

Once the dust settled, the people were able to see Yuan's condition, and to nobody's surprise, he wasn't in perfect shape this time.

The clothes around his arm were torn, and his arm was soaked in blood. Despite this, Yuan wasn't actually in any serious condition, and the injuries on his arm instantly healed due to his perfect regeneration.

However, Yuan would be lying if he'd said that he wasn't nervous about the remaining six strikes.

'I haven't felt this nervous in a while...' He smiled inwardly, feeling a sudden urge of excitement coursing through his profound veins.

When the fourth sword appeared in the sky, Yuan swallowed nervously. As expected, the sword had grown in size, and it was even emitting Sword Qi this time.

'If I want to defeat this trial, I will need to use more than just my raw strength.'

"That sword is exuding Sword Qi! This is my first time seeing this!"

"I have never even heard about this before!"

As the fourth sword descended, Yuan's eyes flickered with a profound light, and his aura exploded outwards.

[Vanishing Ghost's Soundless Blade!]

The Empyrean Overlord was cloaked in a thin yet dense layer of Sword Qi before it was sent flying at the incoming sword.

BOOM!

Hundreds of sword lights scattered in all directions from the Sword Qi's impact, terrifying the spectators who scrambled to dodge it.

A few were not so lucky and were struck by the sword light. Fortunately, nobody lost their lives, but their bodies were badly injured, and it was as though they were struck by a real sword.

"M-Mother! Are you okay?!" Tian Yanyu's heart skipped a beat when she noticed Tian Suyin's arm bleeding.

"I am fine. It's just a scratch." She nodded. "Anyways, let's get further away. Something tells me that this will only get worse. We'll die at this rate."

The spectators scattered like flies once again.

'That one was painful...' Yuan sighed inwardly after blocking the fourth strike, which had cost him both of his arms.

Most would consider Yuan to be crippled now that both of his arms are broken, but within seconds, his perfect regeneration kicked in and restored his arms to its original state.

This monstrous healing ability terrified the spectators who were beginning to wonder if Yuan was even human.

The fifth sword appeared shortly after, and to everyone's surprise, there was no longer just one sword in the air, but two, and they were both big enough to cover the sky.

"Heavens... There are two swords now? There's no freaking way this is possible..."

The spectators were in a daze as their eyes stared blankly at the covered sky.

Yuan took a deep breath after seeing this.

"Young Master... I don't doubt your abilities, but this is..." Feng Yuxiang spoke up in a worried tone.

"I'm not giving up when I'm not even halfway through the whole thing." Yuan said with a nervous smile on his face.

"Why are you pushing yourself this hard? What could possibly be worth risking your life?"

"I don't know, but I will find out soon."

Yuan could only hear a defeated sigh from Feng Yuxiang before he swung the Emyrean Overlord at the two swords in the sky that was descending at the same time.

"Young Master!"

"Brother Yuan!"

Those watching from within his body cried out loud when they saw his arms flying off his body.

Yuan gritted his teeth as intense pain circulated throughout his body.

"This isn't as bad as when I first experienced body tempering..." He muttered as his arms quickly regenerated.

"Holy shit! Did you see that?! His severed arms regenerated almost instantly! What kind of technique is that?!" The spectators were more impressed by his regenerating abilities than his strength that endured the fifth strike.

Of course, most of them were terrified, as they doubted whether Yuan was human or actually a demon in disguise.

"Impressive."

A calm voice suddenly resounded in the area, catching everyone off guard.

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Chapter 1127 Nine Swords Trial(4)

Yuan looked around after hearing this familiar voice, and he quickly noticed that a figure had suddenly appeared in front of him.

This figure was wearing an ordinary mask, yet his body was oozing with an overwhelming aura that naturally made everyone there revere him.

"T-That's the Nameless Emperor! The Nameless Emperor has shown up!"

A few spectators quickly recognized this masked man's identity.

"What do you want?" Yuan calmly asked him.

"Nothing much. I'm just here to congratulate you for surviving through half of my nine swords. Only eight people have achieved this before you, so you're the ninth. A fitting number, don't you think?"

And he continued, "However, do you know how many people have survived the 6th sword? Zero."

"If you wish to survive more than five strikes, you'll need to do more. Think outside the box. I will give you five minutes to think— that is if you still want to challenge me."

The masked figure disappeared into the air as suddenly as he appeared.

'Think outside the box, huh...'

Yuan turned to look at the statue and recalled the previous five strikes.

Two minutes later, he sat on the uneven ground and closed his eyes as countless images flashed by his mind.

'I see... I finally understand the true purpose of this place.'

When Yuan opened his eyes, it shone with enlightenment.

"The sixth strike will descend within 5..."

The countdown started again, and three massive swords appeared in the sky above him.

Yuan took a deep breath and stood in a stance that he'd never done before.

A few seconds later, all three swords slashed at Yuan's tiny body that was like an ant's in comparison.

A vicious aura exuded from the Empyrean Overlord and Yuan.

[Nine Supreme Swords!]

"First Sword Strike!" Yuan muttered as he unleashed his first strike, sending an unfathomable sword light towards the sky.

CLANG!

All three swords in the sky disappeared the instant they clashed with Yuan's technique.

<You have learned Nine Supreme Swords>

[Nine Supreme Swords]

[Rank: Mythic]

[Mastery Level: 1]

[Description: A supreme sword art that consists of nine different strikes, each stronger than the next. Legend has it that the ninth strike has the prowess to cut even gods.]

After destroying the sixth strike, Yuan sneered, "That was the sixth strike? What a scam. In reality, that was only as strong as the third strike of the real technique."

Now that he understood the technique, Yuan realized the true prowess of the Nine Supreme Swords.

Although the Nine Swords Trial claimed the previous attack to be the sixth strike, it was actually not even half of the technique's true potential. After all, this was only a test. If the real technique was displayed, nobody would be able to pass it— not even Yuan himself.

"What kind of sword technique did he just use?! It totally obliterated the three swords!"

The spectators almost couldn't believe their eyes. After all, Yuan had barely survived 2 swords, yet he'd somehow destroyed 3 swords with ease? That didn't make sense no matter how they looked at it.

"Not bad. You grasped the true purpose of this trial. Since it has come to this, let's just skip all the way to the last strike since it wouldn't make much of a difference."

The Nameless Emperor's voice resounded again.

Suddenly, a sword appeared in the sky.

However, there was only a single sword, and its size was that of an ordinary sword.

This puzzled the spectators greatly, as it looked like the trial had given up to them.

Naturally that wasn't the case, and Yuan knew that very well.

While this single ordinary-looking sword may seem insignificant to the others, it looked like an indomitable mountain to Yuan.

'Looks like I will have to go all out if I don't want to lose my life here...' He swallowed nervously.

Whoosh!

Yuan activated God of War's Astral Arts while using all of his soul strength, making the avatar as big as a mountain.

"Heavens! This guy is full of unfathomable techniques!"

The spectators fell to their butts after seeing his avatar that covered the sky more than the swords did.

"Whenever you're ready." The Nameless Emperor spoke again.

Yuan gritted his teeth and swung at the statue before him, utilizing the God of War's Astral Arts as well as his newly learned technique by combining them together.

When both sides clashed with each other, it created a terrifying Sword Qi explosion that literally created a massive crater in the ground.

Fortunately, the spectators were smart enough to distance themselves before that happened, but even then, some of them could not escape the Sword Qi and ended up bleeding from it.

Once the huge dust storm settled, the spectators were able to see the situation.

Hovering above the center of the crater was Yuan, and he was half naked with sword cuts all over his body. And unlike before, his injuries didn't instantly recover, almost as though his regeneration ability was blocked by the sword marks.

"Amazing... To think that was just the prowess of the sixth strike... I cannot wait to see how powerful the ninth strike will be if I ever get to use it..." Yuan couldn't help but praise the technique.

Although the technique was Mythic-rank just like the God of War's Astral Arts, it was entirely different in terms of prowess. Though, one could argue that both techniques serve a different purpose.

While the God of War's Astral Arts is a unique technique that enhances the prowess of other techniques, the Nine Supreme Swords is a technique meant purely for destruction, just like the Heaven Splitting Sword Strike.

"Congratulations, you have passed the trial flawlessly."

The Nameless Emperor appeared before Yuan again.

"Take this, it's your reward."

He extended his hand with his palms open, offering Yuan whatever was on it.

"A silver key...?" Yuan mumbled in a dazed voice as he gazed at it.

His reward for passing this ridiculous trial was just a mere key?

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Chapter 1128 Sword Pagoda

Yuan accepted the silver key shortly after. Although the reward may seem insignificant at glance, it obviously had a significance behind it.

Of course, Yuan saw the Nine Supreme Swords as the real reward for this trial, so he didn't think too much about it.

Once the spectators were certain that the trial had ended, they started crowding around Yuan.

"Young Lord, can you please tell me your name?!"

"Which family do you belong to, Young Master?!"

"Please get away from my friend! Can't you see that he's tried?! Shoo! Shoo!" Tian Yanyu rushed over and started chasing away the crowd.

"Are you okay?" She then asked him.

"Yeah, I'm fine." He nodded.

"Really? Your injuries don't seem to be healing anymore..." Tian Yanyu said as she stared at his half naked bloodied body.

<Due to the lingering Sword Qi in your wounds, your regeneration has slowed down greatly>

"It'll eventually heal itself, and it isn't as bad as it seems— I promise." Yuan smiled.

"Hey! There's something wrong with the Nine Swords Trial! It's not restoring the damage! It should've started by now!" Someone there

suddenly shouted.

Normally, even if the entire platform disappeared, the Nine Swords Trial would restore all damage dealt to the land after every challenger.

"Maybe it's slowed down because of the severe destruction? The damage this time around is incomparably large." Someone said.

"That makes sense. Let's give it some time."

Unbeknownst to these people and the world, Yuan would become the last person to partake in the Nine Swords Trial because it never repaired itself no matter how long passed, as it no longer had a reason to exist.

"Alright, let's head to our next destination—the Sword Pagoda." Yuan said.

"Seriously? You should at least clean yourself before you go anywhere." Tian Suyin said with a slight frown on her face.

"I'll clean myself when we come across some water as we go there."

Thus, Yuan left the scene shortly after with Tian Yanyu and Tian Suyin following him from behind.

Some of the people there tried to follow him, but they quickly gave up after receiving a threatening glare from Yuan.

On their way to the Sword Pagoda, Yuan stopped at a river to quickly wash his blood-stained body.

"Are you really peeking at a man washing himself? When did you become this pervert?" Tian Suyin scolded Tian Yanyu when she noticed her daughter was taking peeks at Yuan in the river.

"S-Shut up! Who's peeking at him?! I looked for a second because I noticed that his body had healed from the sword cuts!" She stuttered while defending her honor.

Tian Suyin couldn't help but also take a look after hearing her daughter's words.

"You're right. Although there are still a few sword cuts left, the majority of them are gone. It's only been two days since then, and I didn't see him consume any recovery treasures during this time either. Either he has a powerful technique or he has a heavenly constitution."

"It's probably a heavenly constitution. After all, it would actually be weird for someone as talented as him to not have a unique physique..." Tian Yanyu said.

"He said he's not from the upper heavens. Do you believe him?" Tian Suyin suddenly asked.

"Does it matter where he came from?" Tian Yanyu raised an eyebrow.

"..." Tian Suyin couldn't answer her question.

"I understand why you doubt him, but he should've proven himself to be trustworthy by now, especially after everything he's done for us."

"Actually, that only makes him more suspicious. I cannot understand his intentions for the life of me... The more I think about it, the more I question it and the more suspicious I get."

"Then stop thinking about it. The moment you do, you'll feel much better, just like I did." Tian Yanyu shrugged.

She also doubted Yuan's intentions before, but she has since stopped caring about it.

"Sorry for the wait. I'm ready to continue." Yuan approached them a moment later.

The ladies turned around to see Yuan wearing a fresh new set of robes, and their eyes widened with surprise after seeing how flashy his new clothes were compared to his old clothes.

"A-Are you actually royalty?" Tian Yanyu couldn't help but ask him after seeing his Golden Dragon Robe, her face blushing nonstop.

"No, this pair of robes was gifted to me by a friend. I don't normally wear them due to how flashy they appear, but since they're very durable and not easily torn, I have decided to wear them. I don't want to change into new clothes after every challenge, after all." Yuan smiled.

"Hm? Are you okay, Senior?" Yuan looked at Tian Suyin, who was biting down her lips, looking like she was enduring something.

'Don't blush. Don't blush. Don't blush. I'm a married woman. I'm a married woman. I'm a...' Tian Suyin repeatedly cried inwardly as she silently nodded her head.

"Then let's go."

After another three days, they arrived at the Sword Pagoda.

The Sword Pagoda looked like a massive sword stabbing the ground from far, but if one got close enough, they would be able to see that it was actually a pagoda with a large sword stabbed in the center of it, almost like a skewer.

There were hundreds if not thousands of people gathered outside the Sword Pagoda at this moment.

"There's a lot of people here..." Tian Yanyu mumbled when she saw the crowd there.

"Well, only 10 people can challenge the Sword Pagoda at a time, and each person takes on average thirty minutes to finish, so you can imagine why there are so many people here." Tian Suyin said.

"Wait... So everyone here is waiting to enter the Sword Pagoda? This will take forever if we wait for our turn. Is there any way to enter earlier?" Yuan asked.

"There are two ways to skip the line. Either you pay the people in the front of the line to take their spot or you can force your way through it with your strength. After all, there is no real queue here. The strongest will go first while the weakest will go last. It's just how this place works." Tian Suyin explained.

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Chapter 1129 Sword Pagoda(2)

"I will go ahead. The two of you should stay back. I will probably make a few enemies in this place, and I don't want to trouble you two." Yuan said as he stared at them with a serious expression.

"That's only natural. I have already used my chance in this place, so I cannot enter it even if I wish for a second chance." Tian Suyin shrugged.

Every individual is only allowed one chance, and this rule is consistent across every trial within the Nameless Emperor's Tomb, so if one had entered Sword Pagoda already, they wouldn't be able to challenge it again even if a hundred years passes.

"I will come back to challenge it once I am more prepared. Since this is my first time entering the Nameless Emperor's Tomb, I am going to take it easy." Tian Yanyu said.

"Alright, then I will be back soon." Yuan left their side and began approaching the Sword Pagoda.

Once he was close enough, Yuan flew into the air to avoid the crowd surrounding the Sword Pagoda.

The people beneath him immediately noticed him, but none of them did anything and merely watched in silence.

However, as he got closer to the Sword Pagoda, Yuan would be assaulted by spiritual attacks from the cultivators.

He silently scoffed at these attacks that were barely noticeable and continued forward.

The front of the Sword Pagoda was almost empty with ten individuals standing out from the rest of the crowd. There was a good gap between these ten individuals and the rest of the crowd, and their aura was much more intense than the others— except for one individual.

It was obvious that these ten individuals would be the first ones to enter the Sword Pagoda.

When Yuan landed before these ten individuals, they all turned to look at him, and some of them even openly sneered in a mocking manner.

"Hey, brat, are you blind? Can't you see that the line is back there? Scram while I am asking nicely." One of the ten individuals, a bald bulky man, suddenly spoke in a loud voice.

Yuan glanced at him and responded nonchalantly, "Are you sure you're not the blind one here?"

The bald man gritted his teeth and started approaching Yuan while veins appeared on his head.

"He's right. If you don't want to die a pointless death, don't take another step." A calm voice suddenly resounded, instantly halting the bald man's movement.

Yuan turned to look at the person who just spoke. He was the only individual there without an aura, but Yuan could tell at glance that he was the strongest there.

This person was an exceedingly handsome young man with silver hair and blue eyes, his body oozing with confidence and arrogance, and he appeared to be around the same age as Yuan.

"You probably can't tell because of the difference between your strengths, but he's not someone you can handle." The silver-haired man spoke again.

The bald man didn't utter any words and merely stood there with a resisting look on his face.

Despite not knowing the silver-haired man's identity, the bald man didn't dare to talk back. Shortly before Yuan's arrival, this silver-haired man showed up out of the blue and silenced everyone there with just his overwhelming aura alone, which was an incredible feat considering that most people there were Spirit Kings.

"I don't recognize you so you probably didn't come from the same place as I, or you're disguised. What's your name, young friend?" The silver-haired man suddenly approached Yuan with a friendly smile.

"Xiao Yang."

"Xiao Yang, huh?" The silver-haired man glanced at his Golden Dragon Robe before continuing, "I didn't think I would meet someone of your caliber down here, much less a human wearing that sort of outfit." The silver-haired man showed his palm and fist and gave Yuan a courteous bow.

"My name's Long Chen, one of Four Dragons and Phoenixes— not that you'll know what it means."

Yuan raised his eyebrows in a puzzling manner. He couldn't understand the intentions of this Long Chen.

However, he understood that this Long Chen probably came from the upper heavens based on his language.

Yuan returned the bow, "I hope you won't mind me standing here with you guys."

"Of course not. If you wanted, you could easily go after me." Long Chen said with a mysterious smile, implying that he was stronger than Yuan.

"What if I want to go after you, too?" Yuan smiled back.

"Hahaha!"

Long Chen started laughing.

"I don't recall the last time someone has talked back to me. The lower heavens are full of entertainment. Why didn't I come down here sooner?"

The people there swallowed nervously after hearing Long Chen's words. Although they had no proof that his words were true, none of them doubted his words.

"So you're from the upper heavens, huh? Which one? Did you come down here specifically for the Nameless Emperor's Tomb?" Yuan suddenly asked.

"I will answer all of your questions if you play a game with me and win." Long Chen said.

"What kind of game?"

"I was going to enter the Sword Pagoda as soon as possible, but I have decided to enter with you. Whoever climbs the highest will win. To make this more enticing, I will even throw in some Royal-grade Spirit Jade."

The people there gasped in shock after hearing such words.

A single Royal-grade Spirit Jade easily cost tens of millions of spirit stones. Only someone from the upper heavens could possibly gamble such a resource so casually.

"Interesting... And what if you win? What do you want from me?"

"If I win, you will answer a few of my questions. Of course, I don't expect you to have any Spirit Jades." Long Chen said.

"Sounds good." Yuan nodded.

"Good."

The doors to the Sword Pagoda suddenly opened, and a figure was flung out of it like trash the very next second.

When this happened, the doors that had been closed this entire time remained open, at least until the next participant entered.

Long Chen was supposed to enter the Sword Pagoda at this moment, but he didn't, and nobody dared to steal the spot, so they all just stood there in silence.

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Chapter 1130 Sword Pagoda(3)

The person who'd just come out of the Sword Pagoda was extremely confused when he saw the situation outside.

Normally, people would be fighting to enter the Sword Pagoda whenever a new slot is opened, but things were different this time. Everyone stood still, almost as though they'd all become statues.

This person stood there awkwardly until another person came out of the Sword Pagoda and a second slot was opened.

"Are you ready?" Long Chen asked as he stared at Yuan.

"Whenever you are." He nodded.

They both turned to face the Sword Pagoda and approached the entrance while walking side by side.

"Good luck, Xiao Yang." Long Chen mumbled in a confident voice right before disappearing into the Sword Pagoda.

"You too." Yuan smiled.

Everyone there released a sigh of relief once the two of them were gone.

"Just who the heck were those two?" The bald man couldn't help but ask.

"I don't know about that man with the black dragon robe, but that silver-haired man is definitely a Young Master with a powerful background in the upper heavens. The question is which one... The Fourth Heaven? The fifth? Sixth?"

"I don't think we'll ever know the truth..." Someone else said.

"So you think that Xiao Yang won't win the bet?"

"Of course he won't! No matter how talented he is, he won't beat Long Chen. Hadn't you felt his aura not long ago? He may be a Spirit King within the Nameless Emperor's Tomb, but his real cultivation is definitely far superior."

"But one's cultivation doesn't matter in these trials, only their innate talent."

"We'll know the answer soon. Let's just wait and see what happens."

"He actually picked a fight with someone from the upper heavens? His arrogance knows no bounds..." Tian Suyin couldn't help but shake her head after witnessing everything from afar.

"He'll be fine... probably... By the way, do you know what is this Four Dragon and Phoenixes that was mentioned?" Tian Yanyu asked.

"No, I don't. But if I had to take a guess, it's probably some title given to geniuses in the upper heavens."

"Most likely... Good luck, Xiao Yang..."

When Yuan entered the Sword Pagoda, he found himself on an empty platform in the middle of nowhere.

There were no walls or ceiling in the background— nothing but the void and the massive platform, almost as though he was in the starry sky without the stars.

A figure wearing a pig mask suddenly appeared 10 meters away from Yuan.

"...A mask with a pig's face?"

This was the first thing Yuan noticed due to its oddity.

"I sense more than one soul within you. Unfortunately, they are not allowed to assist you even though they are your servants." The masked figure spoke, and before they realized, Xiao Hua and the others were forced out of Yuan's body and were transported to another platform where they could only spectate.

"Brother Yuan!"

"Young Master!"

"Don't worry about me. I was going to do this by myself, anyway." Yuan smiled at them.

He turned to look at the masked man and asked, "What now?"

"Before we begin, allow me to tell you the rules of the Sword Pagoda."

"First and foremost, if you die here, you will die for real. However, you are allowed to quit at any time during the trial."

"There are seven total floors in the Sword Pagoda. In order to climb the Sword Pagoda, you must defeat the Guardian on each floor, and you will be given a restriction on each floor including this floor. These restrictions will carry over to the next floor, so you will have a total of 7 restrictions placed on your body by the time you reach the seventh floor."

"Statistically speaking, only one in ten thousand will pass the first floor. One in a hundred thousand will pass the second floor, and one in a million will clear the third. However, after the third floor, you are more likely to encounter a miracle treasure during a stroll than to pass them."

"Now onto your weapons... You are not allowed to use any weapons from the outside. We will provide you with one, and they are all on par with Divine-grade treasures in terms of quality."

"Lastly, you will be given a choice for your reward if you manage to clear the floor after every floor. You have a minute to mentally prepare yourself before I start the trial."

The masked man fell silent after that sentence.

Yuan closed his eyes and took a deep breath.

A minute later—

"The trial for the first floor of the Sword Pagoda will now begin. A restriction has been placed on your body. I will make my first move in ten seconds. Choose a weapon before then."

Ding!

<Your body has been restricted by a mysterious force!>

Yuan suddenly felt as though he had mountains strapped to his back, nearly forcing him to his knees.

'This place might be even more dangerous than the Nine Swords Trial...'
Yuan swallowed nervously as beads of sweat continuously appeared on his face.

"A sword!" He shouted a moment later.

An ordinary sword appeared before Yuan the next second, yet it exuded the aura of a Divine-grade treasure.

The masked man also wielded an identical sword in his hands.

"Eight... Nine... Ten!"

The masked man suddenly sprung into action and began clashing with Yuan.

After a few exchanges with the masked man, Yuan realized something.

'The difficulty isn't my opponent. It's just the restriction on my body that's a problem!'

If it weren't for the restriction on his body, Yuan would have defeated the masked man in a single strike, but because the additional weight that was adjusted for him, even swinging his sword had become a difficult task that required all of his effort.

'If the first restriction is already this cruel, I cannot imagine what the other floors have in store for me!' Yuan cried inwardly as he fought the masked man with sweat pouring from his pores.

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Chapter 1131 Sword Pagoda(4)

"I've never seen the Young Master struggle so much in a fight. His opponent is also weak in comparison, only being at the peak of Spirit King. He would normally defeat such opponents without batting an eye, yet he's been struggling for over 10 minutes now." Feng Yuxiang sighed out loud, breaking the silence.

Lan Yingying shook her head, "Can you blame him? His movements are sluggish and stiff, almost as though there's something weighing him down."

"Brother Yuan will defeat pig face soon. His movements have gotten much better compared to when he first began. He's rapidly adapting to the changes in his body." Xiao Hua mumbled.

"Also, he's not using any of his sword techniques. It's like he's treating this trial as a training ground." Lan Yingying said.

"That's the Young Master for you." Feng Yuxiang smiled.

Indeed, Yuan was getting used to fighting with the restriction on his body. However, that isn't to say that things have gotten easier for him, as the restriction grew stronger as he got more used to it, almost as though it was growing with him.

After another ten minutes of nonstop clashing, Yuan finally managed to defeat the masked man without using any of his sword techniques.

He could've used everything to defeat his opponent in an instant, but if he needed so much resources to pass the first floor, there was no way that he'd pass the later floors, hence why he restricted himself even more by not using any sword techniques.

This also allowed him to familiarize with his situation.

"Congratulations on passing the first floor. What do you want for your reward? Spiritual energy or a Heaven-grade treasure?"

Yuan didn't immediately respond, as he had no need for either of these rewards. His cultivation was stuck at peak Spirit King until he upgraded his physique, and he had no use for a Heaven-grade treasure.

"What if I don't want either of these rewards?" Yuan then asked.

"You can forfeit these rewards and receive an even greater reward on the next floor— if you pass it. If you fail, the rewards on this floor will be forever gone. If you accept a reward on this floor, you can still choose the rewards on the second floor, but it won't be as good."

"Alright, I will forfeit these rewards." Yuan answered without even the slightest hesitation.

"Very well. I will now take you to the next floor."

Yuan's vision flickered for a split second, and the man with the pig mask is now suddenly wearing a mask of a sheep's face.

"Welcome to the second floor. The trial will begin in a minute."

The only thing Yuan could think about now was the second restriction.

A minute later.

Ding!

<Your body has been restricted by a mysterious force!>

"Eh?"

Yuan looked down at his hand with wide eyes. The sensation of his sword had suddenly disappeared, but when he looked, the sword was still there.

'What's going on? Why can't I feel my sword?' He wondered.

"The second restriction has blocked your sense of touch. You won't be able to feel anything except for pain."

"My sense of touch?"

Yuan now realized that even the sensation of the platform that he was standing on had disappeared, and it felt extremely awkward.

One might think that losing your sense of touch isn't that bad, but without being able to tell when your foot touches the ground as quickly, it would instantly throw off one's balance and make movement techniques near impossible. This also affects how one wields and swings their weapon.

"What a pain in the ass..." He sighed out loud.

Ten seconds later, the masked man began his assault.

Now that he's lost his sense of touch, Yuan's movements only became more awkward and unstable, and even the way he swung his sword looked different.

If someone who did not know about the situation were to see him at this moment, they would think that he was drunk to the core.

Yuan knew that it would be pointless to fight the masked man while in such an unstable condition, so he decided to spend as much time as he needed to get used to the restriction. After all, there was no restriction on how much time he had on each floor, so he could stay there for as long as he wanted—needed.

Ten minutes... twenty... thirty...

In the blink of an eye, over three hours have passed since Yuan entered the second trial. During this time, Yuan did not go on the offensive even once and remained defensive.

Once he got used to his new restrictions and could perfectly calculate the moment his foot touches the ground for all of his movements, he started to work on his sword and how he swung it.

In the end, it took him almost four hours to adapt, but once he did, he started going on the offense, defeating the masked man and clearing the second floor.

"Will you choose a reward this time, or will you forfeit it again? The choices remain the same— spiritual energy or a Divine-grade treasure."

"Forfeit." Yuan responded instantly.

"Very well... I shall now transport you to the next floor."

Meanwhile, Long Chen was already on the fourth floor.

Unlike Yuan, who hadn't used any sword techniques up to this point, Long Chen blew away his opponents with his superior techniques from the first floor.

Despite that, he was also struggling to defeat his opponents.

After narrowly passing the fourth floor, Long Chen fell to his knees and muttered in a low voice, "The person who created this place is such a sadistic bastard..."

Long Chen was someone who wasn't used to feeling the ground with his knees. In fact, he doesn't even remember the last time he was brought to his knees.

"I am one of the Four Dragons! There's no way I am going to let some nobody from the Third Heaven defeat me! I am going to defeat the seventh floor and become the first person to clear the Sword Pagoda! Just you wait!"

Long Chen gritted his teeth in frustration.

He forfeited his rewards on the fourth floor and climbed to the fifth floor shortly after.

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Chapter 1132 Sword Pagoda(5)

"Look! Someone's managed to enter the fifth floor!"

The spectators were in awe after seeing a sword light appear on the fifth floor.

There were currently 10 light sources shaped like a sword within the Sword Pagoda, each representing a challenger.

There were six sword lights on the first floor, two on the second floor, one on the third, and one on the fifth floor.

"It must be that silver-haired man from the upper heavens!"

"What if it's that Xiao Yang?"

"Impossible!"

"If you saw what I saw a few days ago at the Nine Swords Trial, you wouldn't say that." Someone suddenly said.

"What did you see there?"

"That Xiao Yang... He managed to survive all 9 sword strikes from the Nine Swords Trial! In fact, he came here right after passing it!"

This person who had witnessed Yuan's greatness at the Nine Swords Trial revealed this information to these people.

"What?!"

Such information greatly shocked everyone there, as they were all aware of the Nine Swords Trial.

"Are you sure you're not farting?! There's no way someone could have defeated that gruesome trial!"

"If you don't believe me, you can go check the Nine Swords Trial! It's probably in ruins right now."

"He's not lying. I was also there to witness it." Someone else there said.

Thus, the name Xiao Yang began spreading in the Nameless Emperor's Tomb.

Upon entering the third floor, Yuan was given another restriction.

The already dim world suddenly turned pitch black, almost as though he'd entered the void.

"..."

Yuan's body trembled as it instinctively knew what had just happened.

The restriction on the third floor had removed his ability to see, turning him blind and causing his bad memories to resurface at the same time.

However, Yuan didn't despair, as he wasn't completely blind. In fact, he could still see perfectly.

This is thanks to his divine sense, which allows him to see things even better than what he could with his bare eyes.

Yuan began fighting with the masked man who had a rooster mask shortly after. Since this floor's restriction was pretty much ineffective against him, it allowed him to fight at the same pace as the previous floor.

This restriction that forces one to constantly use their divine sense may not affect Yuan who essentially has unlimited soul strength due to his soul cultivation technique, but it was deadly to the others, who will inevitably

exhaust themselves from constantly using their divine sense, forcing them to rush through each floor as fast as possible.

Two hours later, Yuan defeated the third floor.

"Will you choose a reward this time, or will you forfeit it again? You can choose between spiritual energy or ten Divine-grade treasures."

'10 Divine-grade treasures? Just how many treasures are in this place?' Yuan wondered inwardly.

"I will forfeit my rewards." He spoke a moment later.

"I understand. Then I shall send you to the fourth floor."

Waiting on the fourth floor was a figure with a goat mask.

<Your body has been restricted by a mysterious force!>

The very next second, Yuan lost all sensation in his left arm.

"So I can only use one arm now, huh? These restrictions are getting more ridiculous." He couldn't help but utter out loud.

"This is just the beginning," said the masked man before approaching Yuan with a movement technique.

'Although his cultivation remains at the peak of Spirit King, his movements are getting better, and he's also more aggressive than the previous guardians. Now that I only have one arm to fight with, I can no longer fight without any techniques. Fortunately, my dominant arm wasn't restricted.'

[Vanishing Ghost's Soundless Blade!]

Due to the increased weight on his body and his crippled arm, he was unable to use his technique at full power.

'I can only exert about 20 percent of its power in my current state...' Yuan sighed inwardly after seeing the effects.

However, even at 20 percent, it was still quite effective against his enemy.

Meanwhile, the people outside the Sword Pagoda watched as the sword light on the fifth floor disappeared.

The door to the Sword Pagoda opened, and a silver-haired young man was sent flying out the next moment.

'Damn it! I was so close to defeating the fifth floor!' Long Chen gritted his teeth in frustration.

After cursing inwardly, Long Chen began sweeping the crowd with his divine sense in search for a certain individual.

'I don't see him... Is he still inside the Sword Pagoda?'

Long Chen looked at the Sword Pagoda to see 5 people on the first floor, 3 on the second floor, and 1 person on the fourth floor.

He turned to look at the group of people in the front and asked them, "Hey, did that Xiao Yang come out already?"

They shook their heads, "No, you were the first to come out."

"Then he's definitely on the fourth floor..." Long Chen narrowed his eyes at the light within the Sword Pagoda.

After taking a deep breath, he spoke in a loud voice supported by his aura, "Starting this point forth, nobody will enter the Sword Pagoda until Xiao Yang comes out! I will slay anyone that dares to disobey!"

"What?!"

It was an unreasonable demand from Long Chen, but nobody there could defy him.

"Who the hell do you think you—"

Some of the newer people there that didn't know Long Chen wanted to fight back, but they were quickly stopped by the others.

"Don't mess with him! He's some bigshot from the upper heavens, and he can kill you with just his aura alone!"

When the newer people learned this information, they immediately gave up on arguing and became silent.

One of many unspoken rules in the Nine Heavens is that one should never mess with someone from a higher realm because messing with even a servant could result in one's entire family being slaughtered, much less a bigshot like Long Chen, who was exuding the aura of a young master from a powerful background.

Thus, nobody else would enter the Sword Pagoda after Long Chen came out. Eventually, everyone else besides Yuan were outside, leaving him alone inside.

Chapter 1133 Sword Tablet

"Fuck! What's taking him so long?! He's been on the fourth floor for 2 hours now!" The spectators were getting impatient, as most of them had only expected to wait at most another half an hour before Yuan got kicked out of the Sword Pagoda.

Even Long Chen couldn't help but wonder what was going on inside.

'What's he doing inside? The third floor forces one to use divine sense due to the restriction, so it wouldn't make sense to prolong the fights. Even if he's not using his divine sense, the guardian should be attacking him relentlessly, giving him no time to rest. To spend so much time on one floor, there's no way he's getting past the fourth floor!'

After another hour of waiting, the sword light on the fourth floor finally moved to the fifth floor.

This shocked everyone there.

"He actually managed to beat the fourth floor after spending three whole hours there?!"

'No way...' Long Chen, who knew very well about the restrictions, was even more baffled than the others.

As someone who climbed to the fifth floor, he knew better than anyone there how unforgiving the Sword Pagoda was, and for Yuan to endure three hours on the fourth floor was nothing short of a miracle.

'What happened in there? I really want to see it!' Long Chen's hands curled up into fists.

"Oh? If it isn't the Silver Dragon. Why are you just standing out here? Aren't you going to challenge the Sword Pagoda?" A voice that Long Chen recognized suddenly resounded.

He turned around to see a group of individuals approaching him from a distance.

Of course, just like Long Chen, they were all from the upper heavens.

"I already went inside," he said in a calm voice, trying his best to hide his emotions.

"Really? Then why are you still here? Hmm? Wow! There's someone on the fifth floor!" These people finally noticed the single light in the Sword Pagoda.

"Why is there only one person inside?" One of them asked.

"Because I am not allowing anyone to step foot inside until that person comes out." Long Chen said, and he continued, "This includes you lot."

"You know who's inside the Sword Pagoda?"

"I don't really know him since we've just met a few hours ago." Long Chen shook his head. "However, he's definitely talented."

"Unbelievable! Did the Silver Dragon just praise someone from this lowly place?!"

"I can't wait to tell the others about this! This is an unprecedented event!"

"I doubt they'll even believe us!"

This group of people started laughing.

Long Chen sneered, "You may mock him for his background, but none of you can compare to this person who came from the very background that you're currently laughing at."

These people immediately stopped laughing after hearing such words.

"Hey, Silver Dragon, cut the crap. You really expect us to believe that someone from this dump is better than us?! There's a limit to your lies even if you just want to mess with us!"

Long Chen glared at the person who just spoke while emitting killing intent, "Cut the crap? Who the hell do you think you're talking to, Mu Shun? If you think I won't dare to kill you because we're down here, you're sorely mistaken."

This person known as Mu Shun trembled in fear.

"I-I apologize. I accidentally blurted out something disrespectful to you because of your outrageous claim that someone from Third Heaven could possibly match us."

"Outrageous, huh? Is it really that unbelievable?" Long Chen pointed at the Sword Pagoda before continuing, "I failed on the fifth floor, so this person who also managed to step foot on the fifth floor is at least as talented as myself. Hell, I would be surprised even if half of you get past the third floor, much less the fourth."

Mu Shun gritted his teeth in anger after hearing such words, yet he couldn't refute it. Nobody there could, so they all remained silent.

Meanwhile, Yuan was already fighting the guardian on the fifth floor with a new restriction, which completely sealed his movement techniques.

Although he could still move his legs just fine, he might as well be considered his legs to be useless since he was only able to move around with the increased weight by using his movement technique.

Now that he couldn't use any movement techniques at all, he would have trouble taking even a single step.

Clang! Clang! Clang!

Despite the new restriction, Yuan still somehow manages to stay on his feet and repel the guardian's attacks with the God of War's Astral Arts.

It was as though Yuan had turned into a mountain with arms. Thanks to the God of War's Astral Arts, he was able to attack the guardian without moving around too much, and each of his strikes would send the guardian flying backwards.

However, the guardian was also relentless in its assault. Every time he gets sent flying, he would run at Yuan again without any pauses.

The two of them would continue this kind of clashing for many minutes until Yuan barely managed to overpower the guardian, defeating him in one strike.

"Will you choose a reward this time, or will you forfeit it again? You can choose between a massive amount of spiritual energy or three Ancient-grade treasures."

'Three Ancient-grade treasures...' Yuan sighed inwardly as he refused the rewards.

A few moments later, he was sent to the sixth floor.

"Congratulations, you are the first person to step foot on this floor." The masked man was now wearing a monkey's mask.

"The sixth floor is a little different compared to the other floors. You will now be given seven days to study this Sword Tablet."

A massive stone tablet shaped like a sword suddenly descended from the void, landing in front of Yuan.

However, there were no words on this Sword Tablet, just multiple deep cuts that seemed to have been left behind by a sword.

"All of your restrictions will be temporarily removed. They will return after seven days, and you will also receive your 6th restriction then. Good luck." The masked man disappeared afterward.

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Chapter 1134 Studying The Sword Tablet

"Heavens! He's managed to reach the sixth floor! I believe this is an unprecedented event!" The spectators outside the Sword Pagoda were in an uproar when they saw the light on the sixth floor.

A look of disbelief appeared on Long Chen's face for a brief moment before his eyes flickered with a vicious flame of various emotions.

Awe, jealousy, shock, inferiority— so many feelings that he hadn't felt in a very long or ever surfaced at once, overwhelming him and his pride.

The others from the upper heavens were also feeling similar emotions.

"Are you sure he came from this dump? How do you know he's not lying to you?" One of them doubted Long Chen's claim that Yuan was someone from the Third Heaven.

"I would've recognized him if he came from the upper heavens!" Long Chen gritted his teeth.

"He could've easily disguised himself."

"Unless he consumed a pill made by the God of Alchemy himself, there's no way I wouldn't realize it!"

Despite saying these words, Long Chen himself was beginning to doubt whether Yuan had come from this Third Heaven or not.

'He was wearing the Golden Dragon Robe, after all... Now that I think about it, there's no way he can acquire something like that in this place,

where the Royal Dragon Clan doesn't exist...'

'But it didn't seem like he was lying when he said that he didn't come from the upper heavens, so where in heaven's name did this guy come from?!'

While the spectators were still trying to get over their shock, Yuan was sitting before the sword tablet, silently staring at the sword marks on it.

'This reminds me of the sword marks in the Mystic Realm...'

Yuan recalled the nameless temple within the Mystic Realm, where he also met Lan Yingying for the first time.

Inside the temple was a tablet with sword marks, and he learned Sword Aura after studying the tablet.

"The sword marks on that sword tablet..." Lan Yingying mumbled in a low voice as she found the sword marks to have a familiar feeling to them.

"Do you recognize the sword tablet?" Feng Yuxiang asked her out of curiosity.

"Not the sword tablet, but the sword marks on it. Although the pattern is different, the marks are almost identical to the ones on the Lord's tablet..." Lan Yingying proceeded to tell the others about her first meeting with Yuan and about the temple that she had spent the majority of her life taking care of.

"So it has something to do with Sword Aura, huh? I wonder what the Young Master is going to learn this time..." Feng Yuxiang mumbled with an anticipating look on her face.

Yuan would spend the next 24 hours staring at the sword marks without any breaks.

Meanwhile, the people outside the Sword Pagoda were confused and filled with curiosity as to what was happening on the sixth floor, and the number of people outside had increased drastically once words began to spread.

This could be a once-in-a-lifetime event, so people were rushing over to the Sword Pagoda.

"It's already been a full day since he entered the sixth floor. Just what is happening inside?"

"This is the first time that someone has ever reached the sixth floor, so nobody can say for sure."

Time passed quickly, and within the blink of an eye, three days have passed since Yuan entered the sixth floor.

During the last three days, nothing significant has happened to Yuan. In fact, he was still trying to comprehend the sword marks.

"It's already been 3 days. Whatever secret is behind that sword tablet, it must be incredibly profound since it usually takes the Young Master no time to understand them." Feng Yuxiang sighed out loud.

However, just as she finished her sentence, an explosive amount of Sword Aura suddenly gushed out of Yuan's body.

"What an immense amount of Sword Aura..." Xiao Hua mumbled in a dazed voice.

Yuan's Sword Aura would only continue to intensify from that moment.

On the fourth day, the Sword Aura around Yuan had become so dense that it could even be seen by one's bare eyes, and it took the shape of a sword, making it seem as though Yuan himself had turned into a sword.

"This is..." Xiao Hua's eyes flickered with excitement when she realized what was happening.

"What is it? Share your insight with the rest of us." Feng Yuxiang noticed this and said to her.

Xiao Hua sneered in a cute manner, silently refusing Feng Yuxiang's request.

"You little..." Feng Yuxiang gritted her teeth in frustration, as she was really curious about Yuan's condition.

"Do you know anything?" She turned to ask Lan Yingying, who was staring at Yuan with wide eyes.

Lan Yingying shook her head, "I have never seen anything like this before, but it feels familiar somehow."

Meanwhile, there were now over 50,000 people surrounding the Sword Pagoda, all of them on the verge of insanity from the anticipation, their curiosity peaked.

"Shit! What the hell is he doing in there?! It's already been four days!"

"Did he die inside or something? There's no way he's been fighting for the past four days!"

"What do you think is really happening inside?"

"Only time will tell."

On the fifth day, Yuan finally closed his eyes and entered a state of trance.

"T-That's..." Feng Yuxiang's eyebrows twitched upon seeing this familiar sight.

"He's experiencing enlightenment once again..." Lan Yingying mumbled with a bittersweet smile on her face.

Most people would be considered lucky if they experience enlightenment even once in their lifetime, yet Yuan has already experienced it multiple times within a year.

Towards the end of the sixth day, Yuan opened his eyes to be greeted by a notification.

<You have learned Enhanced Sword Aura>

"Enhanced Sword Aura..."

[Enhanced Sword Aura]

[Description: Only those blessed by the Sword God could comprehend Enhanced Sword Aura. Allows you to convert your soul strength into Enhanced Sword Aura. Significantly increases sword damage and sharpness.]

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Chapter 1135 Enhanced Sword Aura

After comprehending Enhanced Sword Aura, which is basically a superior version of Sword Aura that uses his soul strength instead of spiritual energy, Yuan's Sword Aura had reached peak masterly level, and his understanding for the swords also increased significantly.

<You have understood the basics of Enhanced Sword Aura>

<Your understanding of swords has reached a new level>

<Your 'Advanced Sword Mastery' has developed into 'Grand Sword Mastery'>

<Congratulations! You have been awarded the title 'Grand Swordmaster'>

[Grand Sword Mastery]

[Description: Very few Swordmasters have reached this level. Drastically improves your control with swords by 75% and increases all damage dealt with swords by 150%. Your enemies will feel more pain from your sword attacks as your damage increases. Your sword techniques will also have more impact. Requires no activation.>

"Brother Yuan really did it... He's learned Enhanced Sword Aura..." Xiao Hua muttered with a look of disbelief and awe on her face.

"What?! Enhanced Sword Aura?!" Feng Yuxiang exclaimed with a terrified expression on her face.

"What's that?" Lan Yingying asked with her head slightly tilted to the right.

"It's not surprising that you don't know about Enhanced Sword Aura since that only exists in the upper heavens." Feng Yuxiang said, and she continued, "Anyways, Enhanced Sword Aura is basically the next level of Sword Aura. It's incomparably stronger compared to Sword Aura and incredibly hard to learn at the same time."

Xiao Hua then spoke, "Even in a place like the Supreme Heaven, where the most talented people in the Nine Heavens gather, anyone that can comprehend Enhanced Sword Aura before they are 100 years old are considered peak prodigies. Brother Yuan isn't even 20 years old..."

"It's that amazing...?" Lan Yingying turned to look at Yuan with a look of admiration on her face.

"There's a saying that if Sword Aura can cut mountains, then Enhanced Sword Aura can split the world into two parts. The fact that it hasn't even been that long since he learned Sword Aura is even more terrifying..." Feng Yuxiang's body trembled before Yuan's unfathomable talent.

"If he's just your ordinary genius, that is." Lan Yingying smiled. "He's the Lord's reincarnate, after all. Something like this should only be natural."

Feng Yuxiang then said, "I don't know anything about this 'Lord', but if he can teach people Enhanced Sword Aura just by leaving behind a few sword marks, I cannot even begin to imagine the level of swordsmanship he'd achieved in his past life."

"By the way, since there's Enhanced Sword Aura after Sword Aura, I can assume that there is something even stronger than Enhanced Sword Aura, right?" Lan Yingying suddenly asked.

Xiao Hua nodded, "Yes, but the amount of people that have reached such a level is so miniscule that it might as well be non-existent."

Shortly after Yuan learned Enhanced Sword Aura, the masked figure returned.

"Congratulations on learning Enhanced Sword Aura. Your restrictions will return soon with an additional restriction."

Yuan couldn't wait for the challenge to begin, as he was itching to use his newfound powers.

<Your body has been restricted by a mysterious force!>

The following moment, Yuan's enthusiasm dropped to zero when all of the spiritual energy inside his body suddenly disappeared.

"The sixth restriction is cultivation restriction. Your Dantian and all of your spiritual energy has been sealed off, so you're no different than a mortal now." The masked man said to him.

"..."

He was already partially crippled before this. Now that his cultivation is sealed, he has truly become a cripple.

Yuan despaired for a second before suddenly recalling the description of Enhanced Sword Aura.

'My spiritual energy may be sealed, but my soul strength is untouched, and Enhanced Sword Aura uses soul strength! I still have a chance!'

If he hadn't learned Enhanced Sword Aura, even all of the talents in the world wouldn't help him pass this challenge.

When Yuan held the Empyrean Overlord, he could immediately tell how drastically different the sword felt in his grasp compared to before learning Enhanced Sword Aura.

'Even though I don't have any spiritual energy, I feel like I can defeat any opponent with this sword in my grasp...'

Yuan's body began emitting Enhanced Sword Aura, creating this weird effect in the air around him that made it seem like it was constantly being sliced by a sword.

In fact, if one closed their eyes and tried to sense Yuan, they wouldn't even sense a human presence, but an entity— a 'sword'.

Yuan stared at the masked man with a tranquil expression. Even though he had no cultivation and his opponent was a peak Spirit King, he didn't feel pressured in the slightest.

The challenge began a few seconds later, and the masked man immediately rushed at Yuan while swinging his sword that was covered in Sword Aura.

Almost as though he was only taking a stroll, Yuan casually took a step forward while swinging the Emyrean Overlord.

Foosh!

An invisible blade of Enhanced Sword Aura flew towards the masked man and clashed with his Sword Aura.

The Enhanced Sword Aura looked easy to dodge at glance, but when the target tried to dodge it, they immediately realized that escape was impossible, as the sharp pressure coming from it was strong enough to instill intense fear in their soul, making them feel as though they'd be cut into a thousand pieces if they dared to move, so their bodies could only stiffen from shock and await its inevitable death.

With a single strike, Yuan had cut down his opponent and defeated the peak Spirit King without breaking a single sweat.

"Enhanced Sword Aura... How terrifying..." Yuan mumbled as he stared at the Emyrean Overlord before showing a slight smile.

"Congratulations, you have defeated the sixth floor."

Another masked man appeared before him.

"You are..." Yuan narrowed his eyes at the masked man.

Unlike the previous masked figures, this one didn't have any weird animal masks and looked more like the real Nameless Emperor.

"Let's have a proper conversation on the seventh floor."

The masked man disappeared afterward.

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Chapter 1136 Weapon Upgrade

"Will you choose a reward, or will you forfeit it again? You can choose between spiritual energy or a Mythic-grade treasure."

A voice tempted Yuan shortly after the masked man disappeared.

"Mythic-grade treasure..." Yuan swallowed nervously.

He would be lying if he said that he wasn't tempted. However, there was still one more floor in the Sword Pagoda. If he forfeits such a reward on this floor, he could only imagine what he'll acquire on the seventh floor.

"I will forfeit the rewards on this floor." He responded a moment later.

"Then I shall transport you to the seventh floor now."

Yuan's body was suddenly enveloped in a warm light before he disappeared from the sixth floor, appearing on the seventh floor.

Outside the Sword Pagoda, over 100,000 people have gathered to witness the spectacle of Yuan reaching the peak of the Sword Pagoda.

"Heavens! He's alive! And he passed the sixth floor!"

"That bastard really did it! He's reached the peak of the Sword Pagoda!"

The people there were all in awe.

The Sword Pagoda is one of the most popular and renowned trials in the Nameless Emperor's Tomb, so most of the people there knew the difficulty and its history.

"A legend is about to be born! Long live Xiao Yang!"

Some people there even began revering Yuan, treating him as though he was a god.

"..."

The group that came from the upper heavens were dead silent at this moment, but all of them were thinking about one thing with serious expressions— that they needed to recruit this person who seemingly has unlimited potential at all cost!

'Regardless if he passes the final floor or not, he's still going to become famous. Once the Seniors in the upper heavens learn of his presence, they will all go crazy trying to recruit him...' Long Chen could feel his heart throbbing with excitement, as it has been a while since a genius at Yuan's level has appeared.

Meanwhile, Yuan stood before the masked man on the seventh floor.

"Welcome to the peak of the Sword Pagoda."

"Are you my opponent for this floor?" Yuan asked as he tightly gripped his Empyrean Overlord.

The masked man shook his head, "No, you won't be fighting me."

"This will be your opponent."

The masked man took a step to the side, clearing the path and revealing the object behind him.

Yuan raised an eyebrow when he saw what the masked man was referring to.

There was a large boulder made of an unknown substance that resembled crystal, and there was a wooden sword stabbed into it.

"That's my opponent? What kind of joke is this?" Yuan asked him.

"This isn't a joke. The condition to pass this floor is to pull out that wooden sword. As for your restriction... Well, this test in itself is one. The rest of your restrictions will also be lifted. Good luck— not that it matters at all."

"Seriously...?"

Yuan felt that it was a little anticlimactic, but he didn't complain. He quickly approached the wooden sword and wrapped his fingers around the handle.

However, before he exerted any force, the masked man spoke, "Oh, before you attempt to pull the sword, I should warn you that you will only have one chance. If you fail, your body will explode, and you will die."

"What?!"

Yuan wanted to release the sword, but he subconsciously pulled his arms back without releasing his grip on the sword.

Sha!

The wooden sword was pulled out of the boulder without any resistance.

Yuan stared at it with wide eyes.

"Ahaha!"

The masked man suddenly began laughing out loud, causing Yuan to raise an eyebrow.

"I was just joking. You wouldn't have died, and the wooden sword has no meaning."

"Explain." Yuan frowned slightly.

"The moment you comprehended Enhanced Sword Aura from the sixth floor, you've already completed the Sword Pagoda. There is no challenge on the seventh floor."

"Then what's the point of making a seventh floor?"

The masked man snapped his fingers, causing a hole to appear in the middle of the room, and inside this hole was about three inches of black liquid.

"Lend me the Empyrean Overlord for a moment." The masked man then said.

Yuan summoned the sword and handed it over.

The masked man looked at the sword with a nostalgic feeling in his eyes. "It's been a while, buddy."

He then submerged the sword in the liquid.

"What are you doing?" Yuan couldn't help but ask.

"How do you feel about the Empyrean Overlord? Is it a good weapon?" Instead of answering his question, the masked man suddenly asked one.

"Well... Despite it being my second Soul Weapon, it's my most used weapon, and I have the most experience with it. When I wield it in my hands, it feels as though it becomes part of my body. It's powerful and easy to use. I don't have any complaints."

"Is that so? What if I tell you that the Empyrean Overlord is actually still in a dormant state? That it's not at its full potential?"

Yuan's eyes widened with surprise upon hearing such information.

"The Empyrean Overlord was crafted by a good friend of mine. He used the best materials in the Nine Heavens, and it took him over ten thousand years to complete it. It could even be considered the best sword in existence. However, its power would've been too potent for you to handle at the beginning, so I purposefully sealed its power until fate brought you here."

"Wait... You're making it sound like you knew I was going to acquire it from the beginning and that I would come here." Yuan frowned.

The masked man lifted his mask a little, revealing his smile, "Of course. That's just how our lives work. Fate isn't as random as it seems, especially

when it's our fate."

"The Empyrean Overlord; the Nameless Emperor's Tomb; the Sword Pagoda... All of these things are connected. You didn't come here by chance. You were guided here."

"By whom?" Yuan swallowed nervously.

"You'll figure it out yourself eventually. Anyways, the upgrade is done." The masked man retrieved the Empyrean Overlord from the hole the following moment.

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Chapter 1137 Awakened Empyrean Overlord

"What do you think?" The masked man handed the Empyrean Overlord that was emitting a totally different aura compared to moments ago back to Yuan.

Yuan swallowed nervously before accepting the Empyrean Overlord.

When he first acquired the Empyrean Overlord, there was always this feeling of it being incomplete to him, like it could be improved. It was a very minor feeling that didn't bother him, but it was there nonetheless.

However, the moment he touched the upgraded Empyrean Overlord, he immediately realized why he had that feeling.

He didn't think it was possible, but the Empyrean Overlord felt even more comfortable in his grasp, and there was even this sense of nostalgia from it.

"Don't be fooled by it." The masked man suddenly said.

"What do you mean?" Yuan looked at him with a puzzled face.

"Its seal may have been released, but it's not fully awakened just yet. In order to fully awaken it, you'll need to feed it lots of spiritual energy. You can do that by killing magical beasts or... other Cultivators." Although it was blocked by his mask, there was a grim smile on his face as he spoke.

"Though, it's still more powerful than the previous Empyrean Overlord even in its current state."

Yuan stared at the sword until a notification popped up.

<Awakened Empyrean Overlord>

<Rank: Soul Weapon>

<Growth Rate: Very Slow>

<Awakening Progress: 0%>

<A godlike weapon crafted by the God of Refinement and wielded by the Sword Emperor. It possesses tremendous power that surpasses all logic. However, it has yet to reveal its true name— its true potential>

<Unique Ability: Qi Devouring Blade>

[Qi Devouring Blade: Activately devours the Qi of your targets after a successful hit]

"A beautiful sword, right?" The masked man asked.

"Indeed." Yuan nodded.

"The Empyrean Overlord and I have experienced and surpassed countless tribulations together in the past. It wouldn't be an exaggeration to say that I wouldn't have survived many situations if it weren't for her."

"Her?" Yuan raised an eyebrow. Why would he address a sword in such a manner? Almost like it had a gender.

The masked man smiled, "About that... You will learn about it eventually."

"Why can't you just tell me now?"

"Because that would ruin the surprise and fun."

"All of you are like this..." Yuan sighed. "What's the point of keeping secrets to yourself?"

The masked man shook his head, "Although we all share the same soul, I wouldn't say that we're all the same individual. At one point in all of our

lives, we had a different personality and lived different lives, so you can say that we're all unique in our own ways. Even if we eventually recover our memories and become nearly identical, it's not completely the same."

"There's a slight difference, and that difference, no matter how small, makes us unique."

Yuan felt some weight lifted from his heart after hearing such words, as he was always worried about returning to his old self— that he had no personality of his own.

"Anyways, the Sword Pagoda will collapse soon now that it has been cleared." The masked man suddenly said as he began walking towards Yuan.

"Here, take this."

The masked man handed a key to him.

"What's this key for? I also received one from the Seven Swords Trial."aid as he retrieved something from his pocket.

"Here, take this before you leave." The masked man handed him a golden key.

"I also got a key from the Nine Swords Trial..." Yuan mumbled.

"What does it do?"

"Collect 9 keys and go to the core of the tomb. Some of the answers that you seek will be there."

Yuan was bewildered. He didn't expect the masked man to actually give him a proper answer.

"Then... Are there any specific trials that I must pass to receive these keys?"

"Yes, there are, but there's no need to worry about it and just do whatever you want in here. You'll eventually find all of them, anyways."

"Are you saying this is the work of fate?"

However, before he could receive an answer, Yuan found himself teleported outside of the Sword Pagoda with Xiao Hua and the others returning to his body.

Once Yuan was outside, he could immediately feel countless gazes staring at him, causing his body to naturally tense up.

He looked around with a look of disbelief on his face, as there were tens of thousands of people there, and they were all staring at him with wide eyes.

After a brief moment of silence, almost as though everyone there snapped out of their daze at the same time, they all began bombarding Yuan with questions.

"What happened on the sixth and seventh floor?!"

"Why did it take you a whole week to pass the sixth floor?!"

"What kind of rewards did you acquire?!"

"Did you pass the seventh floor?!"

"Why did the Sword Pagoda suddenly collapse?!"

"SHUT UP!"

A deafening voice filled with an intense pressure suddenly rippled, startling everyone there and forcing them to hold their breaths.

A few seconds later, Yuan watched as a handsome silver-haired young man approached him with a group of new faces following behind him.

"I will keep this short since it would take too long if I said everything on my mind. Congratulations, Xiao Yang. Not only did you defeat me, but

you've also become the first person in the Nine Heavens to defeat the Sword Pagoda. As promised, I will now answer all of your questions." Long Chen said to him with a defeated smile.

However, Yuan didn't say anything and merely extended his hand, almost as though he was asking for something.

Long Chen chuckled when he saw this, as he immediately realized what Yuan wanted from him.

He reached into his spatial ring and retrieved exactly 10 pebble-sized Royal-grade Spirit Jade before placing them on Yuan's open palm.

The spectators watched while salivating, as these 10 small Royal-grade Spirit Jades were worth over a hundred million spirit stones easily.

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Chapter 1138 Silver Dragon

"Thanks." Yuan said as he tossed the Spirit Jades into his spatial ring.

Long Chen cleared his throat and spoke, "Now as for the questions you had for me... Yes, I am from the upper heavens. Specifically, the Ninth Heaven."

The surrounding people gasped in shock when they heard this information.

"He's someone from the Supreme Heaven?! No wonder why his aura is completely different!"

"A real bigshot!"

"I'm so glad I risked my life to come to the Nameless Emperor's Tomb this year! To think I'd see someone who came from the Supreme Heaven with my very eyes!"

While the spectators there mumbled to each other, Yuan remained relatively calm as he asked, "Oh? I didn't think someone from such a place would be interested in the Nameless Emperor's Tomb. Surely, you're not here for the treasures?"

Long Chen chuckled, "Of course not. The treasures here are as common as tableware in the Supreme Heaven."

"I can't tell you the exact reason why I am down here, but I am searching for a specific individual, but since we're essentially looking with a blindfold on, I decided to spend some time in this place."

'As expected, he's here to look for me...' Yuan sighed inwardly.

"I see... Then I won't bother you anymore. Good luck with your searches." Yuan was prepared to leave as soon as possible since nothing good will come out of staying around these people who were on a manhunt for him.

"Wait a minute. How can you leave already? I still have so much to talk about." Long Chen quickly stopped him.

"If you want to talk, we can do so another time. This place may mean nothing to you, but it means everything to me, and unfortunately, our time here is limited, so I won't entertain you anymore."

"Such insolence! I can no longer ignore your arrogance! Who do you think you are talking to?!"

One of the individuals behind Long Chen suddenly shouted.

Yuan glanced at this person and casually said, "Now that you mention it, I don't know. Care to enlighten me?"

"This bastard—"

"Stop." Long Chen glared at this individual with a serious expression.

"Ignore him, Xiao Yang. Once again, I am Long Chen— one of Four Dragons and Phoenixes. Most people in the upper heavens call me Silver Dragon."

"Silver Dragon? So you're a dragon?" Yuan asked, his interest piqued.

Long Chen shook his head, "Silver Dragon is just a title— one given to those who have been recognized as the most talented in our generation. Amongst the Four Dragons and Phoenixes, only three of them are actually from the Dragon Clan. With that being said, I do have some dragon blood in me. In the Supreme Heaven, the surname 'Long' is mostly reserved for those in the Dragon Clan, after all."

"Oh? So you're a half-dragon?" Yuan asked with an intrigued look on his face.

"H-Hey! That's—!" The group behind suddenly had terrified looks on their faces when they heard the word 'half-dragon'.

Long Chen's eyebrows twitched as a reaction, but he remained calm.

"Since you're not from the Supreme Heavens, I cannot blame you for not knowing, but most people who do not have pure blood would charge at you for using that term. They consider it derogatory."

"Is that so? I will keep that in mind, and I apologize if I offended you."

Long Chen shook his head, "Anyways, I have had this question on my mind since I first saw you..."

His gaze lowered, staring at the Golden Dragon Robe.

"Which Dragon Clan do you belong to?"

"I don't belong to any Dragon Clan."

"What? Then where did you acquire that uniform? If it wasn't given to you by the Dragon Clan, I highly suggest you return it to them. If they learn that a human is walking around with the Golden Dragon Robe, they'll hunt you down like a criminal on death row." Long Chen frowned.

"Then you don't have to worry. It was definitely given to me by the Dragon Clan. Although we're friends, I wouldn't say that I belong to their clan." Yuan said, unaware of the significance behind his outfit.

'Seriously...? Which family would hand out the Golden Dragon Robe to someone that isn't even part of the Dragon Clan? This will easily invoke the wrath of the other clans if they find out...' Long Chen couldn't imagine something like this happening.

After all, an ordinary family within the Dragon Clan wouldn't have something like the Golden Dragon Robe, as only those with royal blood are allowed to possess the outfit.

'In the first place, there are no families with royal blood in the Third Heaven, so he couldn't have possibly gotten it from here. Is he lying about the fact that he didn't come from the upper heavens? Or is he lying about how he acquired the Golden Dragon Robe?' Long Chen pondered with a serious expression on his face, hoping that it was the former reason.

After a moment of silence, Long Chen spoke, "If you don't mind, can you tell me the surname of the family that gave you that robe? I know I am asking a lot of questions, but this is for your own good."

Yuan nodded and responded calmly, "Their surname is 'Xi'."

"The Xi Family?! Impossible!" Long Chen cried out loud after hearing this unexpected information.

Yuan raised his eyebrows and asked, "Why do you look like you just saw a ghost?"

"B-Before I answer your question, allow me to confirm what I just heard... The family that gave you the Golden Dragon Robe is the Xi Family?"

Yuan silently nodded.

Long Chen fell silent again.

"Are you going to tell me that they don't exist or something?" Yuan asked.

"No... There definitely exists a Xi Family with royal blood within the Dragon Clan. However, they have been missing for thousands of years now. Are you sure it's the Xi Family?"

"Xi Shengmo." Yuan suddenly uttered the name of the Dragon Emperor.

Long Chen's eyes immediately lit up after hearing this familiar name.

'That's the Xi Family's Dragon Emperor's name! However, that isn't solid proof that he really met with them...'

"Can you tell me where the Xi Family is right now?" He then asked.

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Chapter 1139 Heading Towards The Sword Temple

"Sorry, but I cannot tell you their location. Although you say they're missing, they separated themselves from the rest of the world on their own accord, and they're living happily from what I saw." Yuan refused Long Chen's request without hesitation.

"They separated themselves? Why would they—" Long Chen halted his mumble when he suddenly recalled the Xi Family's history.

'The Xi Family disappeared shortly after the Dragon Clan's war with Cultivators many centuries ago. I guess they didn't want to deal with humans after what happened...' He sighed inwardly.

But this only created more questions for Long Chen.

'Why would the Xi Family that despises humans give a human the Golden Dragon Robe? This doesn't make sense no matter how I think about it.'

"Anyways, I have entertained you for long enough. If you have more questions, save them for after we all leave this place." Yuan turned around and began walking away.

"How about I come with you?" Long Chen started following him.

He still had many questions and wanted to recruit Yuan to his side, after all.

However, Yuan quickly turned around and held his arms up, pointing his palm directly at Long Chen's face, "Please leave me alone. I already have enough company with me."

"..."

Long Chen halted his steps and no longer followed Yuan.

Yuan quickly escaped the crowd.

"There's too much attention on me. I will meet you guys a few miles ahead." Yuan notified the Tian Family through divine sense as he flew away.

"I've never seen such an arrogant bastard before! He thinks he's above us just because he got lucky in the Sword Pagoda! I doubt he's actually that talented!" The people behind Long Chen gritted their teeth in anger.

"How could someone from a backwater place like the Third Heaven possibly have more talent than us?! He must have used some trick to beat the Sword Pagoda!"

Long Chen couldn't even be bothered by these people and merely remained silent, his eyes staring at the direction that Yuan disappeared to.

'Xiao Yang... What a mysterious fellow.' Long Chen realized at this moment that he's never been intrigued by another individual to such an extent.

Long Chen left the place shortly after, and when that happened, the other people at the Sword Pagoda went into an uproar.

"The Sword Pagoda has collapsed! What should we do now?!"

"I don't think there is anything we can do now..."

"Heavens! He defeated not only the Nine Swords Trial but also the Sword Pagoda! A legend is about to be born! I must let the others know!"

The name Xiao Yang began spreading within the Nameless Emperor's Tomb like a wildfire during a heatwave.

When the big families and powerful sects heard of Xiao Yang and his feats, they immediately decided to recruit him to their side.

"We must find this Xiao Yang before the others and recruit him to our sect!" A famous Sect Leader roared at his disciples.

"My daughter! I want you to meet with this Xiao Yang and bring him to our family at all cost!" A renowned Patriarch said to his precious daughter with an urgent expression.

"But father... You already engaged me to the Ming Family..."

"Screw the Ming Family! This Xiao Yang takes priority! If the rumors are true, he'll definitely become a prominent figure in not just the Third Heaven but the entire Nine Heavens!"

Some people in the Nameless Emperor's Tomb shifted their attention to Yuan after hearing his achievements, treating him as though he was another treasure in the tomb that must be acquired.

However, since the rumors sounded too good to be true, most people doubted it and decided to ignore it.

Meanwhile, a dozen miles away from the Sword Pagoda, Yuan regrouped with Tian Yanyu and Tian Suyin.

"You really dropped a lot of jaws back there— mine included..." Tian Yanyu said as she stared at Yuan, still with a somewhat dazed look on her face.

"..." Tian Suyin remained quiet, her thoughts unknown.

Tian Yanyu continued, "I've been dying to ask you— what happened on the sixth floor? Why did it take you almost a week to pass it when the seventh floor didn't even last an hour?"

"Oh, I was given a week to comprehend something. That's all."

"That's it? Although it's very different from the previous floors, it sounds boring. What about the seventh floor? What did it look like up there?"

"Same as the other floor— empty and boring."

"What about the reward?! You cleared the Sword Pagoda, right? Surely, the reward must be extravagant!" Tian Yanyu's eyes were essentially glowing from excitement at this moment.

Yuan shook his head, "Besides this key, I didn't really receive much."

"Seriously...?" Tian Yanyu was baffled after hearing this, and she looked like a child who just had her dreams crushed.

"Didn't you also receive a key at the Nine Swords Trial? What does it do?" Tian Suyin looked at the key with interest. Her instincts told her that the key would lead to something special.

"Indeed, but I don't know its purpose. I only know that I have to collect seven more before heading to the deepest parts of the tomb."

"That's impossible even for you. Not even half of the tomb has been explored since it was discovered, yet you want to go to the deepest area? You'll just be walking to your own grave."

Yuan smiled, "I think I will be fine. After all, fate brought me here."

'Fate? What a lunatic...' Tian Suyin shook her head inwardly.

"Anyways, my next destination is the Sword Temple." Yuan announced a moment later.

"The Sword Temple is located at the border of the outer area. It'll take us two weeks just to get there even if we traveled there in a straight line without rest." Tian Suyin said.

Yuan nodded, "You don't need to follow me there if you don't want to. I don't want to waste your time, either."

"Nonsense! We've already come this far, it would only be a waste if we stop here! And I'm sure that we'll get to witness something jaw-dropping again, so I won't leave even if you force me!" Tian Yanyu quickly said.

Yuan showed a defeated smile, "Alright, I won't stop you."

They resumed their journey shortly after.

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Chapter 1140 Renowned

<+20 Fame>

<+31 Fame>

<+56 Fame>

<+111 Fame>

Yuan noticed that his Fame was increasing at a rapid rate as he traveled to the Sword Temple.

'This must be due to what happened at the Nine Swords Trial and the Sword Pagoda...'

While he was glad to see his Fame increasing, he still had no idea what kind of effect it had on him.

And in just a few days, his fame reached over 100,000.

Suddenly, an announcement appeared in the sky for all Players to witness.

<Player Yuan's fame has spread far and wide, becoming the first player to receive 100,000 Fame!>

Ding!

<You have received the title 'Renowned' for your achievement!>

<Certain events and areas have been unlocked due to your fame>

Yuan's eyebrows lifted slightly after seeing the notifications.

'So fame unlocks new events... Now the only question is where do I find these events...' He wondered inwardly.

"Xiao Yang, let's take a break."

Tian Yanyu suddenly turned to look at him.

"Alright." He nodded.

They stopped flying and started to look for an area where they could sit down to recover their depleted spiritual energy after flying for days without a break.

Sometime later, they sat below a large tree.

Tian Yanyu and Tian Suyin immediately closed their eyes and began to cultivate.

'I should have a few hours...'

Yuan stared at them for a moment before silently logging off the game for the first time since he entered the Nameless Emperor's Tomb.

'She's still inside, huh?' Yuan thought to himself as he looked at Chu Liuxiang, who was laying beside him with her console on her head.

He went to the bathroom and cleaned himself even though his body was sparking clean despite many weeks of not washing.

After coming out of the bathroom feeling refreshed, Yuan left the room to check up on the others, and as usual, they could be found at the training ground behind the house, but there was only one person there.

"Yuan! What are you doing here? Have you already finished exploring the Nameless Emperor's Tomb?" Wang Ming spoke as he stopped swinging his sword, pleasantly surprised to see him at the training field.

Yuan shook his head, "No, not even close. I'm just taking a small break to stretch my body. Where are the others?"

"They're all in Cultivation Online— that's all we do after morning training nowadays. I'm staying here later than usual since I feel like having a breakthrough soon."

"As for your girlfriends and Jinxi, they only show up once a week to exercise. Meixiu appears a little more often to cook for us, but that has stopped since we told her to focus on her cultivation. The place's been really quiet as of lately with everyone focusing on their own things."

Yuan nodded, "That's good. And since I am already here, want to have a little spar?"

Wang Ming smiled, "I would've asked you if you didn't."

Yuan grabbed a sword and started sparring with Wang Ming shortly after.

Some time later.

"You've improved a lot since our last spar." Yuan said to Wang Ming, who was lying on the floor while soaked in sweat.

"Yet I still cannot land a single hit on you."

Yuan chuckled, "You'll get there, but I won't make it easy."

"That's exactly what I want."

Yuan chatted with Wang Ming for a little longer before he returned to his room.

However, he still had plenty of time left, and he didn't want to return to Cultivation Online so quickly.

Thus, he decided to play with the zither.

After grabbing his zither from the closet, Yuan went to the balcony and began playing it.

About an hour later, Meixiu removed the console from her head and sat up on her bed to look at the clock.

'It's almost midnight...'

Her ears suddenly twitched when it heard a heavenly melody being played, which stimulated her body and instantly woke her up.

"This music... Yuan?"

She quickly went to the balcony before looking towards Yuan's room, and her eyes were immediately blessed by Yuan's handsome face that was enhanced by the moonlight as he played the zither elegantly.

Meixiu opened her mouth slightly only to close it without uttering a sound, as she did not want to disturb such a moment.

A minute later, after playing the final note, Yuan rested his hand on the zither before turning to look at Meixiu with a gentle smile on his face.

"Hey, it's been a while."

"Did something happen in Cultivation Online?" Meixiu couldn't help but ask the first thing in her mind.

"Everything is fine in Cultivation Online, I'm just taking a break."

"I see..." Meixiu didn't know what else to say.

"..."

After a moment of awkward silence, Meixiu subconsciously uttered, "Want to come over?"

By the time she realized what she'd just said, Yuan already responded with a silent nod.

"I will be there in a minute. Let me put away the zither first."

Once Yuan left the balcony, Meixiu's face flushed with redness.

A minute later, Yuan knocked on Meixiu's door.

Meixiu quickly answered.

Once they were inside the room, Yuan sat down and initiated the conversation, "How is your cultivation going?"

"Smoothly. I just entered the 7th level of Spirit Master before logging out."

"You're a Spirit Master already? It's only been a month. I guess this is what happens when you focus on cultivation." Yuan smiled.

She nodded, "The dense spiritual energy in the Third Heaven helps a lot. Of course, my cultivation technique plays the biggest role in my growth. I'm not the only one. Chu Liuxiang and Li Jinxi have also reached Spirit Master. Chu Liuxiang reached the 5th level last week. Though, the one with the most improvement is Li Jinxi. Even though she started much later than us, she has already surpassed us, reaching the 9th level. I think she'll become a Spirit Grandmaster soon."

"Li Jinxi is already at such a level? As expected of the number one genius in the Jaded Garden. She's really talented." Yuan was pleasantly surprised by Li Jinxi's immense growth.

"What about you? How are things in the Nameless Emperor's Tomb?" Meixiu then asked.

"A lot has happened." Yuan proceeded to recall his experience to her.

Chapter 1141 Burst Of Bloodlust

"And that's when I decided to take a break from Cultivation Online." Yuan recalled everything he'd experienced within the Nameless Emperor's Tomb to Meixiu, who listened with an intrigued expression on her face.

However, after Yuan finished his story, the place became dead silent, as neither had anything else to say.

The two of them proceeded to silently stare at each other for the next few moments.

As it has been some time since they last saw each other, and it being the longest that they have been away from each other for a long time, things felt a little awkward between them.

"Meixiu..." Yuan uttered in a low voice, trying to start a conversation.

"Yuan..."

Meixiu misunderstood his intentions and actually kissed him instead.

Yuan didn't complain and closed his eyes, quietly enjoying the soft sensation of her lips.

A few moments later, as her body started heating up with passion, Meixiu began removing her clothes while she continued to kiss Yuan.

Yuan did the same, and within seconds, they were both lying on the bed naked.

"I've missed this warmth..." Meixiu mumbled in a low voice.

"Yeah, me too." Yuan smiled.

They would connect their bodies shortly after, and they would go on to spend the rest of the night cultivating with each other.

Naturally, Yuan completely forgot about Cultivation Online, and it wasn't until the following morning did he recall about the Nameless Emperor's Tomb.

"I'm going to take a bath. Want to come with me?" Meixiu asked him after their passionate session.

"Sure— Oh! I completely forgot!"

"What?" Meixiu looked at him with a puzzled face.

"I have been gone for too long. Tian Yanyu will be puzzled when she finishes her cultivation and I am nowhere to be seen. I'm going to take a quick shower and immediately return to Cultivation Online. Sorry, Meixiu!" Yuan quickly rushed into the bathroom as he spoke.

"Don't worry about it. I am already lucky enough to see you during your brief break. Chu Liuxiang will definitely be upset to know that she'd missed you." Meixiu chuckled.

After a quick shower, Yuan rushed back to his room and logged back into Cultivation Online.

When he returned to the Nameless Emperor's Tomb, Yuan immediately noticed that neither Tian Yanyu or Tian Suyin was there. In fact, the tree that they had been cultivating under was gone as well.

"W-What the hell happened here?!" Yuan exclaimed in a shocked voice after seeing the scenery around him.

The ground around him was split, and it looked like a massive battle had just occurred in this area.

"Do you guys know what happened here? Where is the Tian Family?" Yuan asked his servants.

Unfortunately, they did not know.

"Sorry, Young Master, but we didn't see anything. When you disappeared, our senses were blocked, and we couldn't leave your body either." Feng Yuxiang said to him.

'Damn! I should've left them behind to watch over the Tian Family! I've screwed up!' Yuan cursed inwardly, blaming himself for this situation.

"Yuan, use your Divine Sense and see if you can sense them!" Lan Yingying suddenly suggested. "Your Soul Strength is much more powerful than ours, so you will be able to see further than us."

"Right!"

Yuan immediately activated his Divine Sense to the maximum.

"I found them!"

He quickly found them with Divine Sense.

"They're 25 miles north, and they're currently fighting a group of people!"

He could see Tian Yanyu and Tian Suyin currently being surrounded by a group of unknown Cultivators that clearly had bad intentions, and Tian Suyin even appeared to be injured.

Without hesitation, Yuan immediately began flying towards their direction, his aura filled with killing intent.

'Please let me make it in time!' He prayed as he flew.

Meanwhile, Tian Yanyu and Tian Suyin stood together with their backs facing each other.

"Mother, are you okay?!" Tian Yanyu exclaimed in a panicked manner when she noticed blood flowing down Tian Suyin's right arm.

"I'm fine. Worry about yourself." Tian Suyin said while gritting her teeth.

Tian Yanyu turned to look at the Cultivators attacking them and shouted, "Who are you guys?! We are disciples of the Jade Sword Manor! Why are you attacking us?!"

"Two beautiful ladies traveling by themselves inside the Nameless Emperor's Tomb, you're asking to be attacked! Ahahaha!" One of the Cultivators laughed out loud.

These Cultivators were all wearing unique outfits, suggesting that they might not belong to any sect.

"Are you all Rogue Cultivators? You'll regret attacking us once our friend returns!" Tian Yanyu roared.

"Your friend? Oh, I'm so scared!"

"Hahaha!"

"Nobody is coming to save you! Just give up and stop resisting! If you do, we'll make this painless— less painful for you!"

"Save your breath, Yanyu." Tian Suyin said to her using Divine Sense, "Listen to me. I am going to attract their attention. When that happens, I want you to run away."

"What?! I'm not going to leave you behind, even if I am going to die!" Tian Yanyu immediately refused.

"This is not the time to be stubborn!" Tian Suyin roared back.

"Alright, enough bullshit. Let's just get this over with before we're interrupted." One of the Rogue Cultivators suddenly said.

"I call dibs on the mother!"

"The young one's mine!"

"It's first come first serve!"

Tian Yanyu and Tian Suyin watched as eight Spirit Lords rushed at them with vulgar faces.

A burst of bloodlust suddenly erupted not far away, sweeping the place with a chilling ripple.

This instantly halted not just the Rogue Cultivators but also Tian Yanyu and her mother's movements.

Their initial thought was that they'd somehow attracted the attention of a ferocious magical beast.

However, before they could even think, one of the Rogue Cultivators suddenly shouted out in pain before he collapsed on the ground.

The others turned to look at him with baffled expressions, and they could see a large hole had somehow appeared in the center of his face.

"Yanyu! Senior!" Yuan's voice resounded a moment later.

Tian Yanyu instantly turned to face the direction of his voice with a blissful look on her face.

"Xiao Yang!"

Chapter 1142 Massive Magical Beast

"Mother, let's go!" Tian Yanyu immediately began running towards Yuan the moment she saw him, and she grabbed Tian Suyin's arm before pulling her along.

The Rogue Cultivators were still in shock from their companion's sudden death, so they couldn't react in time and allowed the two of them to escape.

"We'll talk after I take care of the trash." Yuan said to Tian Yanyu as he withdrew the Empyrean Overlord.

Almost as though it was responding to Yuan's emotions, the Empyrean Overlord's aura gushed like water at the bottom of a waterfall.

"W-Wait!" The Rogue Cultivators subconsciously raised their hands to surrender.

They could tell that Yuan was a Spirit King and that nobody there would be able to defeat him even if they all fought together.

However, Yuan wasn't interested in sparring these Cultivators and swung the Empyrean Overlord without hesitation.

A powerful sword light strengthened by Enhanced Sword Qi immediately flew towards the Cultivators.

Everything happened so fast that the Rogue Cultivators couldn't even escape if they wanted, so they had no choice but to try and block the attack.

Unfortunately for them, their techniques were all destroyed as soon as they were deployed.

Nothing could stop the sword light from killing these Cultivators today.

Sha!

The following moment, the Cultivators dropped dead on the ground with their bodies severed in half, their spiritual energy absorbed by the Empyrean Overlord.

[Awakening Progress: 10.01%]

Killing eight Spirit Lord Cultivators was only enough to increase the progress by 0.01%. As for the 10 percent, it actually came from the Sword Pagoda, unbeknownst to Yuan at the time.

Besides the Empyrean Overlord's awakening, the Sword Pagoda rewarded Yuan with all of the spiritual energy he'd gathered from each floor, but since his body couldn't absorb them, it was absorbed by the Empyrean Overlord instead.

Yuan ran back to Tian Yanyu and her mother after dealing with the Rogue Cultivators.

"Senior, you're hurt." Yuan quickly retrieved a pill for her injuries. "Here, take this."

"I'm fine. Where the hell did you go, anyway?" Tian Suyin said as she accepted the pill.

"Sorry, I decided to look around while you guys cultivated. I shouldn't have left you guys alone. This is all my fault."

"Nonsense! Those Rogue Cultivators were 100 percent at fault there! Don't kick yourself for their actions, Xiao Yang. And thank you for saving us. I don't even want to imagine what could've happened if you didn't come in time." Tian Yanyu shivered just thinking about it.

"Anyways, I'm just glad that nothing serious happened to you. I won't leave you two alone anymore. I promise."

"Good, because I am going to cultivate again to recover my exhausted spiritual energy." Tian Suyin said as she sat cross-legged on the ground. She'd used almost all of her spiritual energy to fight off the Rogue Cultivators, after all.

"Me too." Tian Yanyu also sat down and began cultivating.

This time, Yuan stood guard for them while scanning the area with his Divine Sense until they were done.

"Sorry for the wait." Tian Yanyu finished a little faster than her mother since she had a lower cultivation base, thus less spiritual energy to restore.

Tian Suyin opened her eyes two hours later.

Once they were prepared, they resumed their journey towards the Sword Temple.

"What?! Yuan was just awake?!" Chu Liuxiang came out of her room literally ten minutes after Yuan returned to Cultivation Online.

"Yes." Meixiu nodded, and she recalled Yuan's experience for her.

"I can't believe I just missed him... If only I had managed to break through a few minutes earlier!" She sighed out loud.

"You had a breakthrough? Congratulations." Meixiu said.

And she continued, "But even if you came out in time to see Yuan, he wouldn't have any time since he had to rush back into Cultivation Online."

Chu Liuxiang narrowed her eyes at Meixiu in a suspicious manner, "You seem happy—a lot more happy than the last time I saw you. I bet you had a lot of fun with him today."

Meixiu chuckled, "Indeed, I did—the whole night."

Chu Liuxiang sucked her teeth, "Well aren't you lucky..."

"Did he say when he'll take a break again?" She then asked.

"No, but he did say that he will try to take breaks as often as possible."

"That's good to hear."

A week later.

"Hm? There's something happening up ahead." Yuan suddenly warned the others.

"What do you see?" Tian Yanyu asked.

"There's a large group of Cultivators currently engaged in a fight with this massive magical beast. Should we go around them?"

Tian Suyin's eyes flickered with a profound light after hearing this.

"No! That magical beast is an event! If we defeat it, we'll be rewarded!"

"Are you sure? There are already people fighting it. If we enter now and steal their kill, they'll probably come after us..." Tian Yanyu said.

"There's no need to worry. Inside the Nameless Emperor's Tomb, magical beasts are free for all, so it doesn't matter who was first to fight it. If they cannot kill the magical beast and someone comes along to take it from them, they can only blame themselves for not being able to defeat it fast enough."

"Is that so?" Yuan mumbled.

If he had to be honest, he had this urge to fight this magical beast the moment he laid eyes on it, and Tian Suyin's words only convinced him to do so.

"Alright, I'm going to take care of this magical beast real fast and see what kind of reward I'll get from it. The two of you should stay far away just in

case they attack me afterwards." He said to them a moment later.

"I understand." Tian Yanyu nodded.

A few minutes later, Yuan could see the magical beast's massive figure in the distance.

Tian Yanyu gasped in shock when she saw it.

"Heavens..." Tian Suyin was just as surprised. "I have seen plenty of magical beasts before in this place, but none of them could compare to this beast's size!"

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Chapter 1143 Massive Magical Beast(2)

This magical beast in the distance was as tall as a mountain, literally. It stood on all four like a horse, had purple and silver scales, and it had a dragon's head. Furthermore, there was this long, black horn on its forehead, and it was currently shooting out purple lightning from it.

This purple lightning scattered aimlessly, burning anything that it touched. The Cultivators that couldn't dodge it immediately became burnt toast.

"What kind of monster is that?" Tian Yanyu exclaimed in a startled voice after seeing the massive magical beast.

"That's a Purple Lightning Qilin. They're actually a lot smaller in the real world." Tian Suyin responded, her tone sounding a little stiff.

"The two of you should stay here. I will kill it quickly and come right back." Yuan said to them.

"Okay. Be careful." Tian Yanyu nodded without hesitation. The last thing she wanted to do was to get any closer to that lightning-spewing monster.

"His monstrous body will just restore any damage inflicted to him. I bet he's actually immortal." Tian Suyin joked in a serious manner.

"Then I will be right back." Yuan waved at them before flying towards the Purple Lightning Qilin that was running rampage in the distance.

"Watch out! It's going to shoot out lightning again!"

The Cultivators fighting the Purple Lightning Qilin were from different places. Some were disciples of a sect while others were members of a large family. Of course, there were Rogue Cultivators amongst the fighters, but they were mostly fighting alone without anyone watching their backs.

"Ahhh! Fuck! My leg! The bastard's got my fucking leg!" A disciple screamed in agony as he lost one of his legs to the Purple Lightning Qilin's lightning, burning it to a crisp.

"Aim for its horn! If we destroy the horn, it should stop using its lightning attack!" Another shouted.

As Yuan got closer to the battlefield, he could witness with his bare eyes the carnage, where rivers of blood and mountains of corpses littered the ground around the Purple Lightning Qilin.

'There has to be hundreds of corpses down there...' He thought to himself, feeling shivers down his back.

Once he was close enough, Yuan retrieved the Empyrean Overlord.

However, he did not immediately enter the battlefield and patiently waited for his chance to strike. He also studied the Purple Lightning Qilin's movements.

Of course, people continued to die as time passed. As unfortunate as their deaths were, Yuan wasn't going to risk his own life to save these people like some sort of hero. These Cultivators entered the Nameless Emperor's Tomb with the resolve to die, and they did the same before they decided to fight this beast.

About ten minutes later, once Yuan was confident that he knew all of the Purple Lightning Qilin's movements, he tightly held onto the Empyrean Overlord before flying towards it.

'The lightning attack may seem random at first, but it's not. It won't use it again for another three minutes, so this is my chance.'

Yuan appeared directly in front of the Purple Lightning Qilin the next moment, and his body released an aura that surmounted the massive beast before him.

His Empyrean Overlord also gushed with Enhanced Sword Qi.

'This is going to be my first time using Enhanced Sword Qi at its full power!'

After taking a deep breath, Yuan swung the Empyrean Overlord at the Purple Lightning Qilin's horn.

Sha!

The black horn that threatened and killed hundreds of Cultivators had been sliced off the monster's head cleanly.

The Cultivators there were in disbelief at first, but they quickly became overwhelmed with relief after realizing that they no longer have to worry about the lightning strikes.

However, before anybody could celebrate, the Purple Lightning Qilin released a loud roar, causing its scales to turn crimson.

Its eyes also turned bloodshot with red lightning sparking from within, and its body also started shooting out tiny red sparks that coiled all around its body, creating what appeared to be an armor made of lightning.

A sense of dread suddenly assaulted Yuan, and his body instinctively moved.

BOOM!

A massive red lightning strike suddenly descended from the sky, hitting directly where Yuan was flying.

"Argh!" Yuan released a pained voice before slamming his mouth shut when the sudden thunder managed to strike his left shoulder, tearing his entire arm. However, this could be considered lucky for him.

If he hadn't sensed the danger and moved in advance, the thunder strike would've struck his head, instantly killing him.

The Purple Lightning Qilin released another deafening cry, causing more red thunder strikes to rain down.

"Fuck! It's enraged! Run for your lives!"

The Cultivators scattered like ants when they saw the apocalyptic-like scene before them.

"Xiao Yang!" Tian Yanyu was terrified for his life when she saw the situation from afar. In fact, she had to distance herself even further as the area of the lightning strikes appeared to be growing with every passing moment.

'I need to finish this as soon as possible or it'll just get worse!' Yuan thought to himself as he dodged the lightning strikes left and right while he waited for his injury to recover. However, with the Purple Lightning Qilin spamming lightning strikes nonstop, it would be incredibly hard to attack while dodging even if he was uninjured.

Suddenly, a ball of flames shot out from his chest and flew directly at the Purple Lightning Qilin, engulfing its body in phoenix flames.

"I cannot sit back and watch it hurt you any longer, Young Master!" Feng Yuxiang's voice resounded.

Then, a ball of white flames appeared, mixing itself with the phoenix flame, causing the intensity of the flames to skyrocket.

The Purple Lightning Qilin stopped rampaging and began jumping everywhere trying to extinguish the flames, but alas, its efforts were futile, and the flames of two divine beasts only became stronger.

"Thank you, you two!" Yuan immediately took this chance to attack the monster.

[God of War's Astral Arts!]

After summoning his avatar, Yuan swung his sword at the Purple Lightning Qilin again, this time aiming right at the center of its body.

Whoosh!

The sword penetrated the scales with ease before cutting into its muscles, splitting its body into halves.

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Chapter 1144 Sword Temple

After the Purple Lightning Qilin was slain by Yuan, its body immediately began decomposing at a rapid rate until there was nothing but a single item on the ground—a purple key.

Yuan picked up the key and thought to himself, 'Is this what he meant when he said that I'd eventually find them no matter what? Is this a work of fate, or is this the tomb's doing?'

"Brother Yuan, that wasn't a Purple Lightning Qilin. It was an Ancient Lightning Qilin, something that only exists in the Seventh Heaven and above. Even top Cultivators in that realm have trouble dealing with it." Xiao Hua's voice suddenly resounded.

"Have you encountered one before?" Yuan couldn't help but ask her.

"Xiao Hua isn't sure," she said.

"How are you not sure?" Feng Yuxiang then asked.

After a moment of silence, she spoke, "Xiao Hua's memories have been hazy lately. Memories that I don't recall have been appearing in my mind since we arrived in the Third Heaven."

"That is interesting..." Yuan mumbled.

"If I recall correctly, all exiles have restrictions placed on them to make their climb to the upper heaven as hard as possible, such as their strength. Does this mean Xiao Hua's memories have been restricted and such restriction is weakening as we move towards the upper heavens?" Feng Yuxiang theorized.

"That does sound plausible. What do you think, Xiao Hua?" Yuan found such a hypothesis entirely possible.

"Xiao Hua also thinks it's possible. This will also explain why my cultivation suddenly increased when we arrived in the Second Heaven and the Third Heaven." She agreed.

"If that's true, I wonder how strong you truly are, Xiao Hua." Yuan smiled.

"..." Xiao Hua blushed inwardly.

Yuan returned to Tian Yanyu and Tian Suyin shortly after.

"A-Are you okay, Xiao Yang?! It looked painful when you were struck by the Purple Lightning Qilin's red lightning..." Tian Yanyu looked at him with a worried face even though he looked perfectly fine.

"It was indeed a little painful, but it's not unbearable," he said.

"What did you receive from the Purple Lightning Qilin? Surely, it was an amazing reward." Tian Suyin was more interested in the reward.

Yuan showed her the purple key and silently smiled.

"That's it...?" Tian Suyin was dumbfounded.

He nodded.

"No way... These keys better lead to something heaven-defying for them to be considered as a reward..."

"Hopefully. Anyways, let's continue with our journey."

The three of them returned to the air shortly after and started flying towards the Sword Temple again.

A week later.

"Is that the Sword Temple?" Tian Yanyu mumbled as a white building appeared on the horizon.

"It is." Tian Suyin confirmed.

"It's a lot more ordinary than I expected."

The building itself was impressively large, but besides the beautifully detailed design exterior, everything was plain white.

However, that was not what Yuan saw.

While the others may only see an oversized white building, Yuan could see and sense that the entire building was overflowing with Enhanced Sword Aura, so much so that it sent shivers down his back.

Once he was close enough, Yuan could see a large group of Cultivators standing around a tall platform in front of the Sword Temple, where two individuals were engaged in an intense match.

'So that's the Sword Trial...' Yuan thought to himself when he saw it.

This was something he'd read about in Jade Sword Manor's library.

In order to enter the Sword Temple, one must participate in the Sword Trial and defeat their opponent first.

The opponent is different for everyone depending on their strength and talents. If one fails to pass the Sword Trial, they will be denied entry to the Sword Temple, and everyone only has one attempt.

"According to the statistics, less than one percent of challengers have actually stepped foot inside the Sword Temple, and hundreds of thousands of Cultivators participate in the Sword Trial every time the tomb opens." Tian Suyin said as they watched the Sword Trial from afar.

"The summoned Spirits always have the same cultivation as the challenger, but their techniques are usually far superior."

The opponents summoned by the Sword Trial are also addressed as 'Spirits' by most people.

"He lost already? It hasn't even been two minutes since the fight started..." Tian Yanyu mumbled after the challenger was sent flying off the stage with one less arm that he entered the stage with.

"You'd have to be a genius to last more than five minutes against the Spirits. That's how powerful they are." Tian Suyin said.

"The more I witness the Nameless Emperor's Tomb the more it feels like the odds are stacked against us. Just what kind of talent is the creator of this world looking for? Surely, they didn't make it just to mess with us, right?" Tian Yanyu sighed.

The vast majority of Cultivators create a tomb to pass down their legacy to someone worthy, but the Nameless Emperor's Tomb is so difficult that it feels like the creator made it just to mock the challengers.

'Sorry...' Yuan couldn't help but apologize to her inwardly, as this tomb was clearly created solely for him.

Sometime later, they made their way towards the stage before splitting up again.

Yuan went to the back of the line for challengers while Tian Yanyu and her mother went to stand with the spectators.

A few hours later.

"Hm? Look at that young man in the center of the line. Isn't that Xiao Yang?"

A few people who'd just arrived after coming from the Sword Pagoda quickly noticed him.

"You're right! It's him!"

"You mean the genius who cleared the Sword Pagoda?! That's him?! He looks so young!"

An uproar within the spectators quickly ensued, and it didn't take long before everyone was talking about him.

However, the conversation didn't last long, as everyone had their breaths taken away by a group of newcomers.

More specifically, a group of beautiful ladies that instantly stole the spotlight with their peerless appearance, especially the woman with an aloof expression in the front.

Yuan noticed the sudden change in atmosphere and turned to look as well.

'She's strong...' He immediately thought to himself after seeing the beauty in the front.

Chapter 1145 Sword Trial

The lady leading the group of beauties had long black hair, purple eyes with a hint of green, and slight make-up around her eyes. She looked incredibly beautiful but also threatening at the same time, like a rose with thorns.

These ladies were also exuding an overwhelming aura that nobody there has experienced before. They were clearly all from the upper heavens, especially the purple-eyed lady, who had a similar aura to Silver Dragon Long Chen.

However, unlike Long Chen, who was actively hiding his aura, this lady was letting it flow naturally.

These ladies would watch the Sword Trial from afar while mumbling to each other. It was unclear whether they planned on participating or not, but their presence was so heavy that it made focusing hard for the others.

Eventually, people began leaving the line one by one, as they did not want to participate under such an atmosphere. Of course, there were a few that became more motivated since they wanted to impress this group of fairies.

The line quickly grew shorter and shorter until there were less than a hundred people left.

Yuan quickly reached the front of the line, but right when it was his turn to enter the stage, the group of fairies began to move.

The group landed in front of him and blocked off his path to the platform while their leader—the purple-eyed beauty flew onto the stage.

"Wait if you don't want to die a pointless death." One of them said to him.

"..."

Yuan didn't want to argue with them so he remained silent.

"Good luck, Senior apprentice-sister Tang!"

"You'll clear this silly trial with ease!"

These girls began cheering for the purple-eyed beauty, who was surnamed Tang.

Shortly after the Fairy Tang entered the platform, an array formation in the shape of a circle appeared on the other side of the platform, and a figure would emerge from this circle a moment later.

As usual, this figure was wearing a mask, and they had the cultivation of a peak Spirit King.

Fairy Tang kept the same aloof expression on her face, seemingly unfazed by her opponent.

She proceeded to make the first move by pointing her finger at the masked figure.

"Scatter," she uttered in a low but confident voice.

Whoosh!

Thousands of purple-colored flower petals suddenly appeared out of thin air and flew towards the masked figure.

A sweet scent filled the air when the flower petals appeared, but when the surrounding Cultivators sniffed this scent, their consciousness immediately began fading, and those with a lower cultivation could even feel a numbing sensation in their body.

'This is... poison?' Although the poison wasn't effective on him, it wasn't completely ineffective, either.

After all, while his body could take a hit from a spiritual treasure and not receive a scratch, it didn't have much resistance to poison.

The purple flower petals quickly clashed with the masked figure like a tidal wave and consumed their entire figure.

However, a powerful wave of Sword Aura suddenly rippled in the area, instantly destroying the thousands of flower petals.

"Che. As expected, poison won't work on them." Fairy Tang sucked her teeth in an annoyed manner before she retrieved her weapon, a very thin sword that resembled a rapier, and her body also began radiating with Sword Aura.

The Sword Aura released by Fairy Tang was impressive, but it wouldn't hold a candle to Yuan's Sword Aura.

However, Fairy Tang still managed to defeat her opponent after 25 exchanges.

"Heavens! That fairy defeated her opponent within 25 strikes! I don't think I have seen anyone defeat the summon in less than a hundred strikes!" The spectators were filled with awe after witnessing Fairy Tang's performance.

"As expected of Senior apprentice-sister Tang!" Her group cheered.

The other girls in the group proceeded to enter the stage one by one until all of them challenged the Sword Trial.

In the end, all of them passed the trial, but their results greatly differed from each other, ranging between 50 strikes to 100 strikes to defeat their opponent.

"Heavens! I have never seen so many people pass the trial back to back! To think 7 people participated and 7 passed! Truly a spectacle!"

Once the whole group of beauties finally finished, Yuan made his way up the platform.

"Let's head inside the Sword Temple, Senior apprentice-sister Tang." The girls said to her.

However, she remained unmoving as her gaze was fixated on the platform.

The girls turned to look at Yuan and wondered why she was interested in his match.

"Although he's a little handsome, I don't see anything special about him."

"What do you see in him, Senior apprentice-sister Tang?"

Since Yuan had changed out of his Golden Dragon Robe to attract less attention from people like them, he no longer looked as special.

"Look around us. He's the only one who doesn't seem affected by my poisonous scent." Fairy Tang spoke in a calm voice.

When she mentioned this fact, the others also noticed this phenomenon.

"You're right... But is it really that weird? It's not like you're purposefully trying to harm them."

"Perhaps I am thinking too much about it. Let's go." Fairy Tang said as she turned around.

However, before she could even take two steps, her entire body froze when a tyrannical pressure suddenly appeared in the area.

"Who's exerting this pressure?!" The others were also baffled by this anomaly.

They all subconsciously turned to look at the platform.

"It must be that masked figure! She's the cause of this pressure!"

"Wait... This masked figure is a female?"

Indeed, standing on the platform about a dozen meters away from Yuan was a masked figure who was clearly a woman with feminine body, but the most damning evidence were the two large peaks on her chest.

"A masked figure that is a woman! I've never even heard of this before!"
The spectators were just as surprised as the group of fairies.

Yuan narrowed his eyes at this masked figure. He'd watched hundreds of matches before his own, yet none of them had a female opponent, so why did he summon one?

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Chapter 1146 Sword Trial(2)

After being summoned, the female masked figure started looking around with interest, almost as though she was inspecting her surroundings, a behavior that none of the previous Spirits have shown.

Her gaze eventually stopped on Yuan, and after a moment of silence, she spoke in a clear voice, "This is the first time I've been summoned since the creation of this place. What's your name?"

"S-She's having a conversation with her opponent?!" The spectators were beyond shocked by this.

"The Spirits in the Sword Trial have never spoken a single word before!"

"This is the first time it's a woman, too!"

"My name is Xiao Yang." Yuan introduced himself.

"Really?"

To his surprise, the female Spirit questioned his answer, almost as if she didn't believe him.

"I don't like liars, you know," she continued.

"..."

Yuan decided to remain silent.

"Well, whatever. Anyways, are you ready to fight me? I hope you can entertain me."

Yuan immediately retrieved the Empyrean Overlord.

The Spirit's body trembled when she saw the beautiful sword in his grasp.

"You... Why do you have that sword?" The Spirit muttered in a low voice that sounded to be in disbelief.

"Cause it's mine," he calmly responded.

"BULLSHIT!"

The Spirit suddenly roared, and a tyrannical aura exploded from her body, causing the spectators to scatter away from the platform.

"That's my Master's sword! How dare you defile it with your unworthy hands!"

Before Yuan could even respond, the female Spirit suddenly sprang into action, rushing towards him as a large Greatsword appeared in her grasp.

BOOM!

A powerful shockwave appeared when their swords clashed, and Yuan was actually pushed back by the Spirit.

When he stabilized himself, he could feel his entire arm shaking.

'Shit! What terrifying strength!' Yuan cried inwardly, and he realized that this could be the most difficult challenge he's faced in this place yet.

"Die!"

The Spirit did not spare Yuan any time to think and continued to rush at him with her attacks growing stronger with every strike.

Clang! Clang! Clang!

The Spirit eventually started using Sword Aura, causing ripples filled with Sword Aura to scatter everywhere, destroying the platform and the

surroundings.

"Heavens... What am I witnessing?"

The group of fairies from the upper heavens were baffled by the fierce battle, something they thought could only happen in the upper heavens, especially Fairy Tang, who was in disbelief for another reason.

'How... How did he manage to summon an opponent who is far stronger than mine?' Fairy Tang wondered to herself why her Spirit was inferior.

The difference between Yuan's opponent and her own— they couldn't even be compared.

'As far as I know, the Sword Trial adjusts the Spirits based on the challenger's talent. Does this mean the Sword Trial believes that my talent is inferior to that man's talent? That I am inferior to a nobody from the Third Heaven? Impossible!'

Fairy Tang gritted her teeth in frustration. Her existence has always been compared to the others since birth, yet she's always at the top, even when compared to those from powerful families, so she could've never imagined that she'd feel inferior to someone that isn't even from the upper heavens.

As time passed, the spectators would become more and more speechless.

"Heavens... They have been going at it for hours now. It's not weird for the Spirit to not get tired, but that young man is a different story! Just how much energy does he have?!"

Although it may seem like Yuan has unlimited energy like the Spirit, it isn't as simple as that. His body, from his muscles to his bones, are damaged and destroyed with every exchange, but due to his Perfect Regeneration, it completely heals itself before the next exchange.

Of course, even if his body is fine, one's mental state usually degrades as a fight prolongs, but due to Heaven's Indomitable Soul, his mind that is

affected by Soul Strength not only refreshes itself, it also grows stronger with every second.

Therefore, if he isn't damaged faster than he could heal, and if he doesn't use too much Soul Strength at once, he could potentially fight for an eternity without any breaks.

The female Spirit, who had been cursing Yuan nonstop at the beginning, also became quiet.

Minutes turned to hours, and hours turned to days.

In the blink of an eye, Yuan and the Spirit had been fighting each other for five days straight now.

More and more people have shown up at the place just to witness their legendary fight, including the Silver Dragon, who rushed over after hearing the news.

"How long have they been fighting?" One of the newcomers asked.

"They've been at it for five days now."

"F-Five?! Are you messing with me? There's no way anyone can fight that long with such intensity."

"You don't have to believe me. You can ask the others."

Meanwhile, Silver Dragon Long Chen hovered in the air with a pondering expression on his face.

'They've been fighting at this pace for five days now, yet neither of them are using their full strength. That Xiao Yang, is he using that Spirit for training? Even if that's the case, why is the Spirit going along with him?' He wondered, as he thought that the Spirits were meant to defeat the challengers as soon as possible.

"Hm?"

It was at this moment that he noticed the group of beauties standing near the entrance of the Sword Temple.

'So she's also here, huh?'

A smile appeared on his face when he saw the expression on her face. He didn't think he would ever get the chance to see such a sight.

'So even the Poison Phoenix can feel jealousy. What a surprising find.'

He approached her a moment later.

However, Fairy Tang didn't sense his presence until he was right beside her.

"It's been a while, Poison Phoenix." Silver Dragon greeted her with a somewhat cheeky smile.

Fairy Tang glared at him with a cold gaze as she spoke, "What do you want, Silver Dragon?"

Chapter 1147 Sword Trial(3)

Upon sensing the Poison Phoenix's unwelcoming aura, Silver Dragon remained calm as he chuckled, "I don't really want anything from you."

"Then why are you bothering me? Go away, as far as possible, until I cannot see your annoying face with my divine sense." Poison Phoenix coldly sneered.

"Even though I don't need anything from you, I couldn't help but notice you staring at my friend very intently." Silver Dragon said, still with a smile on his face.

Poison Phoenix's expression changed drastically after hearing his words, and she quickly asked, "Your friend? You know that man?"

"Ohho? Am I thinking too much or is the Poison Phoenix, who is prominent for having no interest in anything, actually interested in someone— a man, at that?" Silver Dragon spoke in a teasing voice.

Poison Phoenix began emitting killing intent, "If you value your life, you better watch your mouth when you speak to me, you half-breed dragon."

"..."

Her words wiped the smile off Silver Dragon's face, who also started emitting killing intent.

The ladies with Poison Phoenix shuddered at their clashing killing intent, but the Four Dragons and Phoenixes often fought with each other due to their rivalry nature, so they weren't surprised at all.

"Hmph." Silver Dragon was the first to retrieve his killing intent. "Forget it. I'm not going to fight with you here, especially since it will disturb the Sword Trial. You know what happens if someone disturbs an ongoing challenge in this place, right?"

"I'm not stupid like you."

Poison Phoenix also retracted her killing intent.

There was a strict rule that everyone must follow while inside the Nameless Emperor's Tomb. This rule prohibited anyone from disturbing an ongoing trial. Those who violate this rule will be executed on the spot.

However, even though most people know this rule, there will also still be those who are either ignorant or don't care about the rule.

"Why the fuck is he taking so damn long?! Can't he see that there are other people waiting to take the trial?! Does he think we have an unlimited amount of time in this place or something?!"

A bulky man with long wavy hair and a crusty beard suddenly jumped out of the crowd and towards the platform.

"If you're going to take your sweet ass time, I'll end this for you right now!"

"Stop! What do you think you're doing?!"

The spectators there shouted at him to stop, but nobody dared to physically intervene.

Once the bearded man was about 50 meters away from the platform, an unfathomable pressure suddenly that could only be felt by the man appeared, and it halted the man midair.

"It's over for him."

"What an idiot."

The spectators merely shook their heads upon seeing this.

The next second, the bearded man's expression became filled with horror as his body began twisting like a pretzel stick until it could no longer withstand the pressure and burst like a balloon.

Strangely enough, there was no blood or meat showering the crowd below, almost as though his body was made of air.

A second after the man's gruesome death that was witnessed by all, a profound voice resounded in the head of everyone there excluding Yuan.

"Without exception, those who dare to disturb the trial will be executed."

This voice that was backed by an unfathomable strength sent chills down their spine with some even falling on their butt.

"The creator of this place is truly something else..." Silver Dragon mumbled with a nervous smile on his face.

"Hey, how do you think he would fare against the peak experts in the Supreme Heaven?" He turned to look at Poison Phoenix.

"Why are you still here? Get lost."

Silver Dragon shrugged and turned around to leave, but he stopped again after two steps.

"Oh, right, do you still want to know about that man?" He turned to ask her.

"Scram!" Poison Phoenix growled in a low voice.

However, instead of leaving, Silver Dragon decided to stay and start speaking without looking at her, almost as though he was talking to himself, "Honestly, I don't know much about him, either. His name is Xiao Yang, and we met not long ago at the Sword Pagoda."

When Silver Dragon started talking, Poison Phoenix acted like she couldn't care less, but she was actually listening with interest.

Silver Dragon spoke about how they met and Xiao Yang's achievements at the Sword Pagoda.

Meanwhile, on the platform, Yuan was still focused on his training using the Spirit.

Since the Spirit doesn't seem to have any intentions on defeating him as soon as possible, he wanted to take this chance to train himself, especially since he rarely encounters a powerful opponent like the Spirit.

As for the Spirit, she knew very well what Yuan was trying to do, but she didn't care about it, as this was her first time being summoned since the creation of the Nameless Emperor's Tomb, and as a battle junkie herself, she wanted the fight to last as long as possible.

However, she eventually couldn't be satisfied with their current pace, so she began increasing her power and speed to make things more entertaining.

'If I increase the pace by another 15 percent, would he be able to keep up?' The Spirit wondered inwardly.

But before she could even decide, Yuan suddenly decided to speed up the pace by another 20 percent.

This caught the Spirit by surprise, causing her to miss one of Yuan's strikes for the first time.

Crack!

The tip of Yuan's sword only managed to brush against her mask, but due to the Sword Aura surrounding the blade, it damaged the mask just enough to cut a portion off.

The Spirit stopped fighting and stood still after she realized what had just happened.

"You little bastard... How dare you damage my mask!" The Spirit spoke in a cold voice before she proceeded to remove the rest of the mask, revealing her face to the crowd.

Yuan's eyes widened with surprise after seeing her face, and he subconsciously muttered, "Li Jinxi?"

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Chapter 1148 Jin Xi

To say Yuan was surprised to see Li Jinxi's face behind the mask of the female Spirit would be an understatement.

"Hm? Do I know you?" The Spirit suddenly asked him with raised eyebrows.

"Huh?" Yuan stared at her with a baffled face.

"Why do you know my name? I don't recall introducing myself."

"Your name is Li Jinxi?" Yuan asked for confirmation.

"No, my name is Jin Xi."

"..."

Yuan was speechless.

After snapping out of it, he said, "You're mistaken. I don't know you, but you do resemble someone that I know, and even your name is quite similar."

"Is that so? Then let us continue our fight. I'm going to stop going easy on you now," she said.

Yuan immediately got into position and prepared to clash with her again.

However, Jin Xi's body suddenly erupted with a sharp aura that made those who sensed it feel like they were hundreds of swords stabbing their body, making it difficult to breathe.

Despite that, almost nobody there knew what they were sensing, and only those from the upper heavens had an idea.

"Enhanced Sword Aura!" Silver Dragon muttered with awe all over his surprised face.

Poison Phoenix gritted her teeth in frustration. Even though she doesn't have Enhanced Sword Aura herself, she was experienced enough to understand it when she senses it.

However, for everyone else there, they had no idea that Enhanced Sword Aura even existed.

Seeing Yuan's dazed face, a cheeky smile appeared on Jin Xi's face, and she spoke, "Don't tell me this is enough to make you quit?"

"Hardly."

Yuan chuckled before activating his own Enhanced Sword Aura, but since he'd only recently learned it, it was a little inferior to Jin Xi's Enhanced Sword Aura.

"He also knows Enhanced Sword Aura?!" Silver Dragon exclaimed after seeing it with his own eyes.

'Someone from the Third Heaven really managed to comprehend Enhanced Sword Aura? If he'd been born in the Supreme Heaven, just how terrifying would he be right now?' He wondered inwardly.

"Ready or not, here I come!" Jin Xi shouted right before she began her assault.

Clang!

Bits and pieces of their Enhanced Sword Aura would scatter after each exchange, sending them flying towards the spectators.

When the spectators noticed that their clothes were being cut by an invisible force, they immediately started running away from the stage.

Within mere seconds, pretty much everyone besides Silver Dragon, Poison Phoenix, and her friends were hundreds of meters away from the platform.

"Hahaha! This is what I am talking about!" Jin Xi's laughter echoed loudly.

"Besides my Master, you are the only other person who can satisfy my itch!"

Jin Xi's movement would become faster and faster, and her sword techniques would become sharper and fiercer.

Yuan tried to keep up with Jin Xi's pace, but since this was his first time fighting with Enhanced Sword Aura, he had to put more effort into maintaining his Sword Aura than anything else.

Because of this, Jin Xi would land a few hits on him, but his injuries would heal almost instantly.

"Are you even human, you bastard?" Jin Xi cursed at him when she saw his ridiculous healing abilities.

The two of them would continue at this pace for a few more hours. Even though Jin Xi was seriously trying to win at this moment, she couldn't deal any significant damage to Yuan, and it only got harder to hit him as time passed, as Yuan was improving at a rapid rate.

It took almost half a day, but Yuan's control with his Enhanced Sword Aura eventually became as natural as breathing. This allowed him to focus more on his technique and defeating Jin Xi.

"I think it's about time that we end this. Thank you for the training, Jin Xi." Yuan said to her before his aura exploded.

"You're a thousand years too early to even think about defeating me, junior!" Jin Xi roared, the veins in her arms bulging with vitality.

Perhaps Jin Xi had the power to defeat Yuan, but because she was only a mere Spirit, her strength was limited, and she was destined to be defeated by Yuan today.

After several more exchanges, Yuan managed to break through Jin Xi's defenses and slice her body into two.

Jin Xi's face was filled with disbelief for her last few moments before her body disappeared into thin air.

<You have passed the Sword Trial>

<You may now enter the Sword Temple>

Yuan stood on the stage and silently stared at where Jin Xi disappeared.

'I should've asked her about her relationship with my incarnation before I defeated her...' He sighed inwardly after realizing this missed chance.

However, right as he started to walk off the platform, he suddenly felt a familiar presence appear from behind him.

He turned around, and to his surprise, Jin Xi had reappeared again.

"What is the meaning of this? I thought I had already passed the Sword Trial." Yuan said to her.

"Indeed, you have passed the trial." Jin Xi confirmed.

"Then what are you still doing here?" Yuan raised his eyebrows in a puzzled manner.

"Is there a reason why I cannot be here?" She responded with a question.

Yuan wasn't sure how to answer her question.

"In the first place, don't compare me with the other Spirits. I have a consciousness of my own— even if it's artificial." Jin Xi then said.

"Like the Master of this place?"

She nodded, "Something like that."

"Anyways, besides fighting whoever summoned me, I also have a duty to guide them, so we will be together for a little longer. Are you disappointed?"

"No, I still have some questions for you, after all." Yuan smiled.

"They can wait until you're finished with the Sword Temple. Follow me, I will guide you."

Everybody there watched as Jin Xi, a Spirit, left the platform for the first time.

Yuan didn't say anything else and followed her.

As they both approached the Sword Temple, a group of figures suddenly appeared out of nowhere to block their path.

"Hello?" Yuan said to the group with raised eyebrows as he wondered what they wanted from him.

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Chapter 1149 Poison Phoenix

"Can I help you?" Yuan asked the group of beauties standing before him.

"How rude! Do you know who you are standing before?!" One of the girls suddenly spoke in a displeased manner.

Yuan raised his eyebrows.

"I don't." He answered without hesitation and with a straight face.

This caught the girl who just spoke off guard.

"So, who are you guys?" Yuan didn't wait for the girl to respond and asked.

"I am Tang Meili, one of Four Dragons and Phoenixes, also known as Poison Phoenix. You've heard of us, right?"

If Silver Dragon hadn't told her about Yuan, she would've definitely assumed that he had no idea about the Four Dragons and Phoenixes. After all, they only existed in the Supreme Heaven.

"Yes, I have heard about you guys before. So, how can I help you, Poison Phoenix?"

"Now that you know my identity, you still dare to speak so casually? You're an arrogant one." Poison Phoenix sneered, but she didn't really sound bothered by it.

And she continued, "Anyways, my Tang Family happens to be hiring more servants. Although you don't really qualify at this moment, I'm willing to make an exception. Become my servant."

Yuan was speechless. He didn't expect for her to suddenly recruit her as a servant.

After snapping out of it, he chuckled, "Are you always like this?"

Tang Meili frowned and muttered in a low but cold voice, "What do you mean? And before you answer, I urge you to really think about your words, as there will be consequences for offending me."

Yuan showed a daring smile, "There you go again. How can you say such words with such a calm face? There should be a limit to one's arrogance. Even if you came from the upper heavens, you don't own everyone here, so don't act and speak like you do."

Tang Meili's body visibly trembled after she heard his words.

"How dare you!"

"You're courting death, you insolent bastard!"

"You think you're untouchable just because you are a little talented?! I'll show you!"

The girls with Tang Meili exploded with anger before she could even respond.

"Let's all calm down, shall we?" A familiar voice suddenly resounded.

? It was Long Chen.

'I thought I told him to not follow me...' This was the first thing that came to Yuan's mind when he saw Long Chen.

"Calm down?! I will calm down after I cut off his tongue!" One of the girls said as she leaped forward and swung her weapon at Yuan's face.

Ding!

Long Chen quickly reacted by deflecting the attack.

"Scram!" Long Chen roared, his aura exploding like a bomb.

"Ah!" The girl who clashed with him was sent flying backwards.

His title as Silver Dragon wasn't for nothing. In this place, perhaps only Poison Phoenix could fight him properly.

"Let's attack him together! Even he cannot defeat all of us while his cultivation is restricted to Spirit King!" Someone suggested.

However, before they could act, Tang Meili shouted, "All of you stand down!"

The place became silent again.

"You want to have a go with me? It's been many years since our last exchange, after all." Long Chen beckoned her with a confident smile.

"Hmph." Tang Meili sneered at his words, and she said, "I don't have any business with you today, Silver Dragon."

After saying that, she approached Yuan, and despite Long Chen standing between them, she completely ignored him and walked right past him.

Long Chen didn't try to stop her since he didn't feel any killing intent from her, but he still kept an eye on her just in case.

Tang Meili stopped once she was in front of Yuan.

"I will only ask you this one time. Are you sure you don't want to serve me? My Tang Family is one of the top 10 families in the Supreme Heaven. Although you will only be a servant, nobody would dare to mess with you. If you put in enough work, you might even be allowed to learn our family techniques."

Despite Yuan's earlier remarks that would normally result in a death sentence from her, she still approved and desired his talents. After all, someone who could learn Enhanced Sword Aura in this kind of

environment and at his age would be hard to find even in the Supreme Heaven.

"Thank you for the offer, but I will have to refuse." Yuan responded without needing to think about it.

"Is that so?" Tang Meili closed her eyes and took a deep breath.

When she opened them, they were resolute and emitted a ruthless aura.

"If you're not going to join us, then I don't need to worry about breaking you."

Tang Meili's words implied that she was going to destroy him, but she didn't do that and simply turned around and began walking away.

"Senior sister, you should break his limbs at the very least for looking down on you."

"I'm not the type that enjoys stepping on ants, but I will kill him if he ever dares to step foot in the Supreme Heaven." Tang Meili said in a cold voice.

"That's it? I was hoping for a good show." Jin Xi said in a disappointed tone after Tang Meili and her group were gone.

Yuan looked at her with slightly widened eyes and said, "You're going to let them attack me? What kind of guide are you?"

Jin Xi shrugged, "I'm your guide, not your guardian. And you already have a guardian, so why are you expecting something from me?"

Yuan turned to look at Long Chen, who was silently smiling at him.

"Is everyone in the Supreme Heaven like that?"

Long Chen shrugged, "I can't speak for everyone, but that's how many people in the Supreme Heaven view those from a lower realm. After all, even beggars up there have a higher cultivation than everyone down here.

Though, the Poison Phoenix showed a lot of restraint back there. Normally, she'd kill anyone that dares to talk back to her."

"Is that so? What about you? How do you view the people down here?" Yuan suddenly asked him.

A cold smile appeared on Long Chen's face as he replied, "Of course, you're all nothing but ants in my eyes."

"You think I am an ant as well?" Yuan raised an eyebrow.

"In your current state? Yes, you are. I don't mean to sound conceited, but even with my cultivation restricted, I can easily crush you with a single finger. You may have potential, but that's all you are right now— potential."

"..."

Long Chen continued, "You are probably thinking that you have a few cards up your sleeve since I haven't seen you fight at 100 percent, but the same goes for you."

Yuan shrugged, "Even if you are wrong, I have no reason to prove you wrong. If you have nothing else to say, I am going to leave."

Long Chen was slightly shaken when he noticed Yuan's unwavering eyes.

'Does he really believe that he could have a proper fight with me?' He almost couldn't believe it.

However, before he could even say anything, Yuan had already left his side and entered the Sword Temple.

Since he has yet to pass the Sword Trial, Long Chen could only watch as Yuan's back disappeared into the building.

Chapter 1150 Sword Temple

'As I thought, it's dangerous for me to be around these people from the upper heavens. They're nothing but trouble.' Yuan sighed inwardly as he entered the Sword Temple with Jin Xi.

Inside the Sword Temple was so dark that Yuan couldn't even see his own hands, almost as if he'd entered the void.

"What kind of place is the Sword Temple? This seems different from what I've read about." Yuan asked out loud. Even if he couldn't see her, he could feel Jin Xi's presence beside him.

"The Sword Temple is different for everyone. What you see and hear will depend on your talents and fate."

Yuan didn't say anything else and proceeded to wait for something to happen. However, when nothing happened even a few minutes later, he spoke again, "So, what am I waiting for?"

"Be patient. The Sword Temple is possessing your information. It could take hours to days until it finishes," she said.

"Should've said so earlier..." Yuan sighed.

He then took a seat and closed his eyes.

"Hey, can I ask you some questions?" Yuan decided to start a conversation while they waited.

"That depends on the question."

"The one you address as 'Master', is he the creator of this tomb?" He was pretty confident he already knew the answer to this question, but he wanted to be sure.

"That's right. My Master is all-knowing and powerful. There's nobody in the Nine Heavens stronger than him."

She spoke in a bragging manner.

"What's your relationship with him? How did you end up as his servant?"

"Servant? What an outrageous assumption, you asshole. What made you think I was serving him?"

"You're not? The way you act, I guess."

"I call him master because I am his disciple!" She exclaimed, sounding quite offended.

"Oh, really? My bad."

Yuan was surprised. He didn't expect to have disciples in his past life. Though, if he thought about it, it wasn't too shocking.

"So did he own a sect?"

"No. Master wasn't the type to stay in one place for long. He's always traveling. Even if he did, he wasn't exactly Sect Master material."

"Then how did you end up as his disciple?"

"..." Jin Xi fell silent for some reason.

"I don't want to talk about it," she mumbled a moment later.

"Then tell me about him. What kind of person was he?" Yuan asked.

"Hmph. You've already asked enough questions. It's my turn to ask some," she said.

And she continued, "First of all, where did you get that sword from the Sword Trial."

"The Empyrean Overlord?"

"So you even know its name..."

"I acquired it from someone else. She found it in this place, too."

"Is that so? And it accepted you as its master, right?"

"That's right."

"Who are you, really?" She then asked.

"Xiao Yang."

"Don't give me that shit again. Your real name."

Yuan smiled, "My name is Yuan, and I came from a place called Earth."

"Earth? Never heard of it."

"Well, it's not within the Nine Heavens, so I am not surprised."

As ridiculous as it sounded, Jin Xi didn't call him a liar, almost as if she knew.

"Why did you come to this place?" Jin Xi suddenly asked.

"Fate brought me here, I think."

Jin Xi sneered at his answer for some reason.

"What's wrong?" Yuan asked.

"You sounded like my master, who always talks about fate."

"Really? Can you tell me about him? The creator of this place is shrouded with countless mysteries, after all."

After a moment of silence, she spoke, "Even though I've known him for thousands of years and even followed him for a good majority of those years, there's a lot that I still don't know about him. Hell, I don't even know what he looks like since he's always wearing a stupid mask for some reason."

'Well, you do now...' Yuan smiled inwardly.

"Master was always in the spotlight, even during his childhood. His immense— heaven-defying talents would attract attention no matter where he went. He also had a lot of enemies and couldn't go a week without fighting someone, most of them being people who envied his talents."

"Master learned Sword Aura at a young age and mastered Enhanced Sword Aura before he even turned 30, earning him the title of Godly Sword Emperor. He is also the first and only person to have ever reached the level of whatever is beyond Enhanced Sword Aura."

"He was so famous that his existence was known throughout the Nine Heavens, yet it seemed like nobody knew his true name or face. I wanted to follow him until the end of time, but alas..." Jin Xi sounded disappointed towards the end, even a little regretful.

"Did something happen?" Yuan decided to dig deeper.

However, Jin Xi shook her head and said, "I don't know. That's the extent of my memories."

"Is that so... Then do you know why he created this place?"

"Nope." She answered without hesitation.

"Master's thoughts are too profound for someone like me. All I am good for is swinging the sword."

Yuan couldn't help but chuckle at her words. She greatly resembled Li Jinxi not just in appearance but nature as well.

He wanted to say something, but his attention was stolen by a white glow that had suddenly appeared in the distance.

"What's that?" He asked.

"You're about to find out," she said.

Whoosh!

The white glow that started out as a small dot quickly expanded until it consumed all of the void, turning the entire place white.

Thud.

Thud. Thud. Thud.

The sound of approaching footsteps began echoing in the place shortly after.

Jin Xi's eyes slowly widened as she recognized this familiar sound.

A tall figure wearing an ordinary-looking mask appeared in the distance a moment later.

"Master..."

Jin Xi muttered in a trembling voice as she slowly kneeled on the floor and lowered her head.

The masked man stopped in front of Yuan.

"Welcome to the Sword Temple," he said.

Chapter 1151 Divine Gaze

"So, what are you going to make me do now?" Yuan asked the masked man, who stood before them with his hands clasped behind his back.

However, the masked man didn't say anything and merely took a seat in the lotus position, and he would remain as still as a rock without uttering a single sound for the next few minutes.

This caused Yuan to raise his eyebrows. He wasn't sure what he was waiting for or how long this would take.

"Are we still waiting for something to happen?" He decided to ask Jin Xi, who looked at him with a slight frown.

"Seriously? The trial has already started," she said, taking him by surprise.

"What? Where? What's the rules?" He continued asking.

Jin Xi pointed at the masked man and said, "Figure it out yourself."

After saying that, she returned to staring at the masked man's figure with an admiring expression on her pretty face, looking like a little girl before her idol.

"..."

Yuan no longer bothered with her and also took a seat.

'What am I supposed to do? I don't sense anything from him.' He wondered to himself as he stared at the masked man, pondering about the trial.

The masked man had no aura, his breathing was so subtle that it was almost nonexistent, almost as though he was on the verge of death.

Many minutes later, still having no idea about the trial, Yuan turned to his companions for assistance.

'Do you guys know what is happening here?'

"No idea." Feng Yuxiang responded without hesitation.

"I also don't know." Lan Yingying shook her head inwardly.

"..."

Xiao Hua's response took a little longer, "Although he seems to be cultivating, the spiritual energy around him is completely still, so that's not possible. Perhaps he is training Sword Aura? Xiao Hua can't tell because she cannot sense it."

"That's what I thought at first as well, but I cannot sense an ounce of Sword Aura from his body." Yuan shook his head.

He began walking in circles around the masked man as he pondered more about the Sword Temple's purpose.

However, no matter how much he racked his brains, he was unable to grasp the situation.

Eventually, Jin Xi snapped, "Stop pacing around Master like he's some kind of object at an exhibit! Show some respect! You're also disturbing me by blocking my view!"

Yuan shrugged, "What can I do? He's literally left no clue about this trial, and I cannot figure it out."

Jin Xi facepalmed and sighed, "Why did the Master even show himself to an idiot like you?"

"That's quite harsh... But can you really blame me here? This trial is different for everyone, so it's not like I can prepare for this."

After sighing again, Jin Xi spoke, "Listen up, I will only say this once."

"What you're doing right now is pointless. You'll never get anywhere even in a million years at your current pace. If you want to understand the situation, stop looking at the surface and start looking deeper."

"Stop looking at the surface and look deeper?" Yuan repeated in a mumbling voice.

He turned to look at the masked man again.

'His breathing... The sound of his heartbeat...'

Yuan suddenly entered a trance where he was completely focused on the masked man, paying attention to the pace of his breathing and even the rhythm of his heartbeats.

However, Yuan felt that wasn't enough, but he didn't know how to look deeper.

Then, almost as though an invisible lightning bolt had struck him and gave him divine epiphany, Yuan subconsciously started using divine sense in a new way.

Normally, one expands their divine sense outwards to see as much and as far as possible, but Yuan did the opposite and condensed his divine sense until it only had the masked man in its sight, allowing him to see the masked man like he was looking through a microscope.

Unfortunately, he was only still able to see the exterior.

Immediately, Yuan tried something different.

This time, he condensed his divine sense even more, and he used it to enhance his own eyes.

Yuan's eyes quickly widened with surprise.

'I can see... I can see everything! From his muscles to the bones! I can even count his blood cells individually!'

<You have learned Divine Gaze>

[Divine Gaze]

[Rank: Divine]

[Description: Allows you to see the world in its purest form]

"Divine Gaze... What a powerful technique..." Yuan mumbled out loud.

Jin Xi raised her eyebrows and spoke, "Huh? You just learned how to use Divine Gaze?"

"That's right." He nodded.

"How surprising. Given your talents, I thought you already learned it. Guess I overestimated you a little. Anyways, don't get too happy just yet. Learning Divine Gaze isn't the true purpose of this trial."

"Eh? It isn't?" Yuan looked at her with wide eyes.

And since he still had Divine Gaze activated, he accidentally glimpsed at Jin Xi's bountiful body for a brief second before it stopped working before he could even deactivate it.

"Che."

Jin Xi sucked her teeth in a disdainful manner.

"The first thing you do after learning Divine Gaze is to peek at a maiden's body? You're the worst."

"I didn't do that on purpose..." Yuan quickly apologized to her.

Then he asked, "By the way, did you block my Divine Gaze? I cannot see through you even though it's still activated."

"Just like how you can use your Divine Sense to block others' Divine Sense if you have superior Soul Strength, you can block others' Divine Gaze with Divine Sense. After all, Divine Gaze is essentially Divine Sense, and they both require Soul Strength."

"The only reason you can use Divine Gaze on Master is because of the nature of this trial, so don't think for a second it'll work on everyone, especially those stronger than you." Jin Xi lectured him.

"I see..."

"Anyways, you're still in the middle of the trial. Don't disturb me again until you're done."

After saying that, Jin Xi returned to staring at the masked man.

"..."

Now that he learned Divine Gaze, Yuan realized that she'd been using it on the masked man this entire time. This realization sent shivers down his entire body since she was technically looking at him, but he decided to ignore it and returned to focusing on the trial.

Chapter 1152 Sword Body

After turning away from Jin Xi, Yuan returned to focusing on the masked man with Divine Gaze.

Very quickly, he realized something.

'T-This is... His muscles and bones are enveloped in Sword Aura!' Yuan cried inwardly after realizing this.

However, that was just the beginning.

"No... Even his blood cells are enveloped in Sword Aura?! How is that possible?!" He exclaimed out loud, his eyes filled with interest.

"Did Brother Yuan just say his blood is enveloped by Sword Aura?" Xiao Hua's voice resounded a second later.

"Yes... It seems like everything inside his body, from his muscles to his blood cells, are covered in Sword Aura." Yuan confirmed.

"Do you know what is going on, Xiao Hua?" He then asked.

"Un. He has achieved what is known as a Sword Body. This is only possible when one unifies the very essence of Sword Aura with their own body. Only those with extreme understanding of Sword Aura and talent could achieve a Sword Body. Since ancient times, there has never been more than 10 Swordmasters that have achieved a Sword Body at any given time within the entire Nine Heavens, and less than 100 Swordmasters have ever achieved this state." Xiao Hua explained to him.

"Is that so... A Sword Body, huh?" Yuan mumbled in a dazed voice.

Then he realized something, "Wait... Does this mean that he's telling me to achieve a Sword Body right now?! How am I even supposed to do that?"

"If he's your incarnation, you should be able to achieve it, Young Master." Feng Yuxiang said.

"How long does it usually take for one to achieve a Sword Body? Assuming they have what it takes to even achieve it." Lin Yingying asked out of curiosity.

"Hard to say, but nobody would be surprised even if it took those with a Sword Body over ten thousand years to achieve it. That's just how extremely rare they are."

"Over ten thousand years?" Yuan swallowed nervously upon hearing this.

Even if he was a genius, this trial will probably take him a long time to complete. Hopefully, he'll finish it before the tomb closes.

"Xiao Hua, do you know the process of attaining a Sword Body?" He asked her the most important question.

"Sorry, Brother Yuan, but there is very little information about Sword Bodies in general. Unless you learn from those with a Sword Body, nobody can really say for sure what it takes to achieve it."

"No worries. I guess I'll start by unifying my Sword Aura with my body—at least try to."

And without saying anything, Yuan took a seat in front of the masked man and began inspecting his body again with Divine Gaze.

However, even after staring for many minutes, Yuan still didn't know where to start.

'How do I even unify my Sword Aura with my body? Which part of my body do I start from?'

Eventually, Yuan just started by releasing his Sword Aura, enveloping his entire body with it.

The Sword Aura would gush outwards, even creating ripples, but no matter what he tried, Yuan couldn't get it to go inside his body.

Minutes turned into hours, and hours quickly turned into days.

Within a blink of an eye, six days have passed since Yuan entered the Sword Temple.

"What's going on inside? It's almost been a week since he went inside. Most people come out after a day or two. I hope nothing happened to him..." Tian Yanyu sighed in a worried tone while her eyes were glued to the Sword Temple, unwilling to look away until she saw Yuan's handsome face come out.

"Have you not been watching him for the last few trials? You should know by now that he's not the type to die easily. Save your worry for something that's actually worth worrying about." Her mother shook her head.

Despite sounding cold, she also showed her confidence in Yuan with such words.

"I know, but I cannot help but worry."

"You sound like his mother. Heck, since when were you the type to worry so much about others? Are you really my daughter? Where did my selfish and cheeky little brat go?" Her mother looked at her with suspicious eyes.

"W-What are you talking about?! Do you have any idea how much he's helped our family? The least I can do is worry about him!"

"Helping our family? Everything he's done up to this point was mostly for you! I'm actually shocked that he hasn't outright proposed to you yet."

Tian Yanyu's face immediately flushed with redness.

If they looked at it from that point of view, Yuan's action would make more sense to them. But to be fair, there's no way anybody would have guessed Yuan's true reason for helping them. In fact, even if Yuan told them, they wouldn't have believed him.

A full week eventually passed.

'He wants to achieve a Sword Body before the tomb closes in less than half a year? Hmph. Not even the Master could do such a thing, much less this greenhorn. Master was considered as the number one genius in the Nine Heavens during his era, and it still took him a little over a hundred years to achieve his Sword Body.' Jin Xi sneered inwardly at Yuan's ambition and ignorance.

Shortly afterward, Jin Xi's eyes gradually widened as she watched the masked man suddenly open his eyes and stand up, before walking behind Yuan and sitting down again.

'What is Master doing all of a sudden?' She wondered inwardly.

Yuan wasn't aware of the masked man's movements, as he was too absorbed in his own thoughts, almost as though he was in trance.

Meanwhile, after taking a seat, the masked man lifted both of his arms and gently placed his palms behind Yuan's back, looking as though he was trying to help Yuan cultivate.

'It can't be! Don't tell me he's trying to—' Jin Xi almost couldn't believe her eyes.

Moments after the masked man's action, Yuan's Sword Aura that was gushing outward gradually began to weaken. However, if one had Divine Gaze, they would be able to tell that the Sword Aura was actually permeating into Yuan's body.

'M-Master's guiding him! But why?!' Jin Xi exclaimed inwardly, her jaw dropped.

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Chapter 1153 Sword Body(2)

'What's happening? It suddenly feels like I know how to unite Sword Aura with my body.' Yuan was surprised when his Sword Aura began entering his body. It also felt like he was being guided by someone, but he still wasn't aware of the masked man helping him. However, he didn't think too much about it and continued to follow the guidance, slowly combining his Sword Aura with his body.

Time passed quickly, and within the blink of an eye, half a month has passed since Yuan entered the Sword Temple.

'He's still inside, huh. It's been too long. Did something happen to him inside?' Long Chen pondered. He came out of the Sword Temple three days after Yuan entered the place and has been waiting for him to come out since then.

'As far as I am aware, the Sword Temple isn't a dangerous place and nobody has died inside before, so what is he doing inside?'

He wasn't too worried about it, especially when he recalled how long Yuan took in the Sword Pagoda.

Eventually, another half of a month passed with Yuan nowhere to be seen.

It has been an entire month now since he entered the Sword Temple. During this time, rumors about Yuan dying inside the Sword Temple have spread throughout the Endless Emperor's Tomb.

This greatly shocked everyone, mostly because they all believed that the Sword Temple was a safe zone where one couldn't die.

Many were also filled with pity knowing that a peerless genius had passed away in such an unfortunate manner.

"I don't believe it. There's no way Xiao Yang died inside! He is still alive! He must be!" Tian Yanyu refused to believe the rumors.

"No matter what you believe, it won't change the fact that he's been inside for a month now. We have less than 4 months left before the tomb closes. If we stop wasting our time and leave now, we can still regroup with the others."

"I refuse! I will not move from this spot until Xiao Yang comes back out!" Tian Yanyu exclaimed with a stubborn face.

Her mother could only silently shake her head.

Meanwhile, inside the Sword Temple, Yuan was still being guided by the masked man. After a month of constant assistance, his Sword Aura is almost fully unified with his body. Even someone as tremendously talented as Yuan required the help of his incarnation and a month to reach this point, proving how ridiculously difficult it was to acquire a Sword Body.

However, in the eyes of Jin Xi, his progress was still unbelievably fast.

'Even with Master's help, he's managed to reach this point in such a short amount of time. This kind of talent is unheard of...'

Several more hours later, the masked man finally lowered his arms and stood up.

'Is it done? Did he achieve a Sword Body?' Jin Xi used her Divine Gaze to look at Yuan's physique.

"This bastard... He really did it... He really achieved a Sword Body at that age..." Jin Xi muttered in a shaky voice, her body trembling as well.

At this moment, Yuan's Sword Aura could not be sensed, almost as though it did not exist. However, if one were to look inside his body, they would

see that all of his internal organs and muscles are being protected by Sword Aura.

<Congratulations, you have achieved a Sword Body>

<You have gained the title 'One With Swords'>

<Description: With a Sword Body, your body can no longer be harmed by Sword Aura and other Auras. Your proficiency with swords have been increased by 10,000%. Your physical defense has increased tremendously and will continue to grow as you strengthen your Sword Aura.>

Yuan was pleasantly surprised by the bonuses he gained from having a Sword Body. Being immune to Sword Aura and other weapon Auras could even be considered overpowered.

"You better thank the Master for his assistance. If it weren't for him guiding you, you would've never achieved a Sword Body." Jin Xi suddenly said.

"So that feeling was because of you, huh. Thanks."

The masked man then said, "Take out your sword."

Yuan nodded and retrieved his Empyrean Overlord. When he held onto the sword, it felt like the sword had melded into his hand, almost as if it had become his arm.

"Now attack me with everything you've got," he continued.

"Sure thing." Yuan said without any hesitation since he wasn't worried about killing the masked man.

After taking a deep breath, Yuan swung the sword at the masked man without using any sword techniques. However, the force coming from the strike was immense and wouldn't lose to when he used an Ancient-rank sword technique before acquiring a Sword Body.

This greatly surprised Yuan, who did not expect such prowess coming from a normal sword slash.

Despite that, the masked man managed to catch his sword, and he'd done it with two fingers.

Yuan wasn't too surprised by this and asked, "Satisfied?"

"For now. At your current level, you will be able to handle the inner areas without too many problems."

"Speaking of the inner area, that is where I plan on going next."

The masked man nodded and turned to look at Jin Xi, who quickly straightened her body.

"Take her with you. She'll be your guide, but don't expect her to protect you from the dangers within."

"I know." Yuan smiled.

"And thank you, Jin Xi."

"It's a pleasure that I could be of use to you again, Master!" She smiled brightly.

However, Yuan could feel a sense of sorrow coming from the masked man, which made him curious about their relationship even more.

"Hey, what's your relationship with her?" He had to ask.

"If you really want to know, you can ask her."

"I already did, but she refused."

The masked man merely shrugged in silence.

"Anyways, it's about time for you to leave. You have been here for a month already, after all."

"What?! A month?!" Yuan exclaimed in a shocked voice. He must've experienced another enlightenment since it doesn't feel that long for him.

"Then I will teleport you two out now." The masked man waved his sleeve, sending them away.

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Chapter 1154 Entering The Inner Areas

After being teleported out of the Sword Temple, Yuan found himself standing at the entrance of the building.

"I hope I didn't inconvenience the Tian Family too much by being gone for so long without any explanation..." Yuan quickly rushed outside as he activated his Divine Sense, hoping to find Tian Yanyu and her mother.

Sure enough, he found them standing not too far away from the Sword Temple.

He immediately rushed over after seeing them.

"X-Xiao Yang!" Tian Yanyu was the first to notice him since she had been staring at the Sword Temple this entire time.

"You're alive! I knew it!" She was clearly overjoyed to see him again.

"I am really sorry! I had an enlightenment in the Sword Temple and lost track of time!" He immediately lowered his head and apologized to them.

"You had an enlightenment...?" Tian Suyin's eyes widened upon hearing that.

"No wonder why it took you so long to come back out! And congratulations on your enlightenment! Even the Elders at my Sect have never experienced one! You're too amazing, Xiao Yang!" Tian Yanyu's eyes shone with excitement.

Tian Suyin's eyebrows twitched at such words, as she was also a Sect Elder.

"Sorry for not being part of the one percent that experienced enlightenment, and sorry for not being amazing." The irritation in her voice was obvious.

"S-Sorry... I didn't mean to mock you..." Tian Yanyu quickly realized her mistake and apologized.

If they knew that this wasn't Yuan's first or even second enlightenment, who knows how they would react.

Sometime later, Yuan spoke with a guilty look on his face, "I really hope you guys haven't been waiting for me this entire time."

"Hmph. I told her we should just regroup with the others after waiting for 2 weeks, but this stubborn girl kept refusing, so yes, we have been waiting here for an entire month." Tian Suyin said.

Tian Yanyu's face flushed with redness as she silently nodded.

Yuan felt incredibly guilty for making these two ladies wait an entire month for him, so he decided to postpone entering the inner area to help them a little more.

"I was going to enter the inner areas after this, but I will hold that off for a little longer. Do you guys have any specific places that you wish to visit? I will take you there as an apology," he said to them.

"You really don't have—"

"I do!" Tian Suyin interrupted.

Yuan smiled at her, "Where would you like to go?"

"I have always been interested in this place, but due to it being at the edge of the inner area, I never really had the courage to go. However, now that we have a monster like you with us, I think it's possible!"

And she continued, "It's a place called Sword Graveyard, where thousands of powerful swords are rooted into the ground. Rumors are that each sword

has a powerful sword technique hidden within, meaning that there could be potentially thousands of sword techniques to be learned there."

"Oh, I read about that place. I wanted to go there, as well." Yuan said.

"Then it's settled. Let's go there now. Though, I don't really know how to get there since it's not near this area." Tian Suyin said.

Yuan turned to look at Jin Xi and asked her, "Do you mind showing us the way? You're a guide, so you should be able to do that at the very least, right?"

"Yes, I don't mind showing you the way to the Sword Graveyard." She nodded with a nonchalant face.

"Wait... She's coming with us as well? Isn't she a Spirit from the trial? Is that even allowed?" Tian Yanyu asked.

Yuan nodded, "She's a special case."

"It'll be even more reassuring if she's coming with us." Tian Suyin smiled.

"Oh, she won't protect us even if we are in danger. She's just a guide." Yuan quickly said. He didn't want them to have the wrong idea later on when she refuses to protect them.

"Is that so... What a pity. Anyways, it shouldn't be too dangerous since it's going to be on the edge of the inner area."

They left the Sword Temple shortly after.

"You know, there's a rumor going around claiming that you have died inside the Sword Temple." Tian Yanyu said to Yuan as they traveled.

"I'm not surprised." Yuan chuckled.

A week of traveling later, they arrived at the border of the Nameless Emperor's Tomb's inner area.

"This should be obvious, but the inner area is nothing like the outer area. It's much more dangerous with many more magic beasts and other entities roaming around. The trials will also be more brutal. Less than 1 percent of people who enter the inner area make it back out alive." Jin Xi warned them.

"Other entities, huh..." Yuan mumbled.

"By entities, she's probably talking about demons." Tian Suyin said.

"Oh, right, I read about this before, but I didn't care about it since I never imagined entering the inner areas." Tian Yanyu sighed.

"Unfortunately, they are not something even you can handle, Xiao Yang. We must run if we encounter one." Tian Suyin said to him, unaware of his demon slaying expertise.

"Hoh? They must be really strong then. I can't wait to fight one. I like a good challenge, after all." Yuan decided to play dumb and act like he's never encountered a demon before.

"Are you even listening to me? Unless you know demon sealing techniques, it's nigh impossible to kill them because of their immortality. I do not want to repeat myself again—we must run if we encounter one!" Tian Suyin spoke with a frown on her face.

"If it's Xiao Yang, maybe he can kill them..." Tian Yanyu said, showing her absolute trust in his abilities.

Tian Suyin facepalmed at her daughter's blind trust in Yuan.

"Whatever. If you really want to fight it, I won't stop you, but I will also not stay to fight it with you. I am not reckless, after all."

"Of course." Yuan nodded with a smile.

Chapter 1155 What Just Happened?

Yuan and the others stepped into the inner area of the tomb after mentally preparing themselves.

The second their feet touched the ground in the inner area, they felt the atmosphere instantly change, and it suddenly felt as though they'd entered another world—a world that is filled with death and a place that humans don't belong.

"This is worse than I thought..." Tian Suyin muttered as she subconsciously pinched her nose to avoid the smell.

"What the... Where did this stench come from? It wasn't there just a second ago!" Tian Yanyu was baffled.

"You cannot see it, but the inner area and the outer area are separated by an invisible boundary. In fact, they can be considered as their own world." Jin Xi said.

"No wonder..." Tian Yanyu mumbled.

"You guys should block the smell with your spiritual energy." Yuan said to them.

"No need to state the obvious. I was just surprised by how sudden it was." Tian Suyin said with a slightly rosy face as she stopped pinching her nose.

They followed Jin Xi deeper into the area shortly after, entering a heavily forested area.

Everything seemed normal for the first several minutes, but Yuan suddenly stopped walking and said, "Careful, there's a demon coming our way."

"Huh? What nonsense are you talking about? I don't sense any—" Jin Xi said, halting her sentence halfway through.

"No way... There's really a demon approaching us. How did you sense it before me?" Jin Xi was pretty proud of her own sharp senses. Unfortunately for her, no matter how sharp her senses are, they would never defeat Yuan when it comes to sensing demons.

In fact, Yuan could sense multiple demons in their area with some of them being hundreds of miles away.

"What are you waiting for?! Do you really plan on fighting a demon?! I'm telling you, they are far more terrifying than whatever you're imaging right now! We need to leave right now!" Tian Suyin exclaimed in a nervous manner when she noticed that Yuan didn't seem to have any intention of running.

"We'll be fine." Yuan reassured her, but his words didn't sound convincing at all.

"Forget it! Yanyu, we're leaving him behind! If he wants to die that badly, we'll grant his wish!" She quickly gave up on trying to convince Yuan and went to grab Tian Yanyu's hand.

However, Tian Yanyu didn't budge despite her pulling.

"Yanyu...? What do you think you are doing...?" Tian Suyin looked at her with wide eyes filled with disbelief.

"I'm going to stay here with Xiao Yang." Tian Yanyu responded in a low voice with a subtle smile.

"Have you really gone mad...?" It was at this moment that Tian Suyin realized that Tian Yanyu was no longer the daughter she knew, as she has drastically changed since meeting Yuan.

"You should calm down a bit, little girl." Jin Xi suddenly spoke, causing Tian Suyin to freeze.

"Little girl...?" Tian Suyin almost couldn't believe her ears. This was her first time being called a little girl by someone who looked to be in her early twenties.

"Although it may not seem like it, I am actually over 100,000 years old— at least before I died." Jin Xi smiled.

"Really?" Even Yuan reacted with surprise when he learned of this information.

Tian Suyin was only 300 years old herself. If one compared their age, they would understand why Tian Suyin would only be a little girl in Jin Xi's eyes.

"Anyways, if you want to leave, you can leave. Though, I think your worries are unnecessary." Jin Xi then said.

However, before Tian Suyin could say anything else, a terrorizing pressure appeared in their area, causing her body to freeze from fear.

And from the edge of her eyes, Tian Suyin could see a red figure walking towards their direction.

'It's over...' She cried inwardly.

'That's a demon...? Mother was right... It's reckless to even attempt fighting them...' Tian Yanyu fell on her buttocks after sensing the astronomical amount of killing intent being emitted by the demon.

Just its gaze alone snapped Tian Yanyu back to being clear headed.

"You think you can kill it? It's too late to run now." Jin Xi looked at Yuan with a cheeky smile on her face.

"If you beg me to help you, I just might disturb the demon for a moment," she continued.

Yuan chuckled, "Thanks, but no thanks."

He summoned his Empyrean Overlord and began walking towards the demon in a slow and relaxed manner.

This made Yuan recall his first encounter with a demon, but he was not as naive and weak as he was back then.

"Foolish human..." The demon uttered in a mocking tone after seeing that Yuan was approaching it instead of running away.

"A lowly demon, I don't even have to use my demon sealing aura to deal with you."

Like the lowly demon it was, it immediately lost control of its temper and forcefully rushed at Yuan.

Seeing this, Yuan pointed his sword at the incoming demon.

The demon suddenly vanished into thin air the very next second. This befuddled Tian Suyin and Tian Yanyu, who had no idea what had just happened.

"W-What just happened?" Tian Suyin asked in a dazed voice.

"He killed it." Jin Xi answered after a brief moment of silence.

"What?!" Both Tian Suyin and Tian Yanyu exclaimed.

Jin Xi then explained, "He surrounded the demon with Enhanced Sword Aura just now, shredding its body into pieces so small that it can't be seen with just one's bare eyes. But he didn't stop there and continued to cut the demon until its last cell was destroyed. After all, a demon can fully regenerate from even a single blood cell."

Tian Suyin swallowed nervously after hearing Jin Xi's explanation, but she doubted if something like that was even possible.

"Is something like that really possible?" Tian Yanyu asked what was on her mother's mind.

"Can it be done? Of course, since it just happened right before your eyes. However, it requires one to have perfect control over their own Sword Aura and a tremendous amount of Sword Aura, and missing either one will make it impossible, something 99.99% of Sword Masters cannot replicate." Jin Xi said.

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Chapter 1156 Sword Graveyard

"So that was a demon, huh? They're not as strong as I thought." Yuan said, still putting up the act that this was his first encounter with a demon.

However, Tian Suyin immediately saw through his act and pointed at him and shouted, "Y-You think this is funny?! There's no way that was your first fight with a demon since you clearly knew about its regeneration abilities, or else you wouldn't have done something so ridiculous as your first move!"

Yuan smiled at her remarks and asked, "Even if I told you that I have the ability to kill them, would you have believed me?"

"T-That's..." Tian Suyin immediately became speechless, as there was no way that she'd have believed him.

"You're really full of surprises, Xiao Yang." Tian Yanyu said with a dazed face.

"Not only have you encountered them, you seem very experienced with fighting them. Where'd you learn that, hm?" Jin Xi looked at him with an intrigued gaze.

"I will tell you if you tell me your relationship with the masked man." Yuan smiled at her.

"Wha— Why do you care so much about my relationship with another man? Are you jealous?" She laughed.

Tian Yanyu stared at Yuan intensively.

Yuan shrugged, "Will you tell me if I admit that I am jealous?"

"No," she immediately replied.

Yuan merely shook his head in silence before speaking, "Anyways, let's continue."

They started moving again shortly after.

"Xiao Yang, are you really jealous?" Tian Yanyu asked him using divine sense.

"Huh? No way."

"Then why do you care so much?"

"To tell you the truth, I have some connections to the masked man, so I was just interested."

"What?!" Tian Yanyu exclaimed in a shocked voice after hearing this.

"Why are you suddenly shouting?" Tian Suyin frowned.

"S-Sorry..."

Jin Xi glanced at them. She contemplated listening in on their conversation, but knowing Yuan's ability, he'd easily realize it.

"Keep it a secret, okay?" Yuan chuckled.

"Of course... But how do you know the masked man? Isn't he the creator of this place?"

"I don't actually know him. Sorry, I don't know how to explain it. It's complicated."

After all, it wasn't as if he could say that he was the masked man's reincarnation.

"Is that so..." Despite her curiosity, Tian Yanyu didn't pursue the topic any longer.

After walking for a little longer, Tian Yanyu suddenly asked, "Hey... I just noticed this, but why are we walking? Wouldn't it be faster if we flew there?"

"If you wish to be spotted easily by demons and magical beasts, by all means, I don't mind flying." Jin Xi said.

This quickly made Tian Yanyu speechless.

"A-Actually, never mind. I was being too shortsighted," she apologized in an embarrassed manner.

"Wait a second." Yuan suddenly jumped in, and he continued, "That's actually not a bad idea. Time is precious in this place, after all. Don't worry, I will deal with any danger that we encounter."

"..."

Normally, this is where Tian Suyin objects and starts calling him reckless.

However, after what she witnessed before, she realized that Yuan was not the reckless type and that he had the power to back up his confidence.

"Since nobody is objecting, let's start flying now." Jin Xi said as she ascended into the sky.

Literally not even five minutes later, Yuan could sense demons approaching them.

"Be careful, we have three guests." Yuan calmly warned them.

"Three?!" Tian Suyin exclaimed.

"Don't worry, they are all low-ranking demons. I can deal with them with closed eyes."

"This guy..." Tian Suyin was speechless.

"Whooohooooo!"

An excited voice suddenly resounded from a distance.

"It's been over a hundred years since I last tasted humans!"

"Lucky me!"

The three demons laughed merrily as they surrounded Yuan's group.

Tian Suyin and Tian Yanyu subconsciously moved closer to Yuan when they felt the demons scanning their bodies with starved eyes.

"Let's feast!" One of the demons suddenly rushed forward.

Yuan raised his arm and pointed at the incoming demon before unleashing his Sword Aura.

Almost instantly, the demon's body was shredded until there was nothing left.

This shocked the other two demons, who had no idea what had just happened. And while they were scrambling to make sense of the situation, Yuan unleashed his Sword Aura for a second time, killing another demon.

The remaining demon trembled, and with hesitation, it turned around and began flying away at maximum speed.

"Where do you think you are going?" Yuan sent his Sword Aura chasing after the fleeing demon.

The demon could feel the lower part of its body quickly being consumed by the Sword Aura, but it could not run any faster. In the end, its life also perished to the Sword Aura.

After dealing with the three demons as though it was nothing but a walk in the park, Yuan sighed in a disappointed voice, "It's a pity that I can only target one of them at a time right now."

Tian Suyin looked at him with a baffled face.

'Is there anything that he can't do?' she wondered inwardly.

"Let's continue, shall we?" Yuan smiled at them, acting like nothing had just happened.

Eventually, they arrived at the Sword Graveyard. It took them nearly half a month, and they had encountered over a hundred demons on their way there.

"One of you here must be a demon magnet." Jin Xi said, because of their abnormal number of encounters with demons.

Yuan could only show a stiff smile regarding her remarks.

"So this is the Sword Graveyard, huh? It exceeds my imagination..." Tian Suyin mumbled, her face full of delight, almost like a child at an amusement park for their first time.

Before her was a large field with thousands of unique swords plunged into the ground, invoking a sense of both awe and sadness. The sheer number of swords was overwhelming, and it made Tian Suyin wonder why this place existed.

Had these swords been discarded? Is this truly a burial ground for swords? Or is there a deeper meaning for this place?

"All these swords... What a waste." Tian Suyin sighed. As someone who walked the path of a sword master, this sword graveyard was a sorrowful sight.

When Yuan first laid eyes on the Sword Graveyard, his body froze, and for some inexplicable reason, he started feeling many emotions that he could not explain.

Chapter 1157 Sword Graveyard(2)

"X-Xiao Yang? Are you okay?" Tian Yanyu asked him when she noticed that he had tears in the corner of his eyes.

However, almost as though he couldn't hear her, Yuan remained silent as he stared at the graveyard.

Perhaps he'd recognized these swords. Even though he himself might not remember them, his soul remembers the time they had spent together.

In his daze, Yuan started to approach the Sword Graveyard, and it even looked like he wanted to reach for one of the swords there.

When Tian Suyin saw this, she immediately sprang into action and grabbed him by the collar before yanking him back.

"Whoa?!"

This snapped Yuan out of his daze.

"Are you crazy?!" Tian Suyin shouted at him afterward.

"You cannot touch these swords! Anyone that does so will face severe punishment!"

"Eh? Really?" Yuan expressed genuine surprise, as he didn't know about this.

"Many people have tried to take a sword from this place, but all of them have perished after being punished. Even Immortals have died in this place, so no matter how talented you are, even you won't survive." Tian Suyin explained.

And she continued, "The only thing we are allowed to do here is study these swords and hopefully learn something from it."

"Is that so... Sorry, and thank you for waking me up. I don't know what just happened to me." Yuan said.

"Are you okay?" Tian Yanyu asked him again.

"Huh? What do you mean?" Yuan asked with a puzzled face, still unaware that he had been crying just now.

Tian Yanyu pointed at his eyes and said in a low voice, "You're crying..."

"What?"

Yuan quickly wiped his eyes, and sure enough, it was wet.

"Why did I...?" He muttered in a dazed voice.

Jin Xi silently stared at Yuan with narrowed eyes, seeming in deep thoughts.

"Pft. That idiot really tried to take a sword from this place..."

"Why did she have to stop him? It would've been a spectacular sight to see him get punished."

Yuan suddenly heard voices that he was unfamiliar with, and they were laughing at him.

He looked around, and it was at this moment that he realized they were not alone.

There were over a hundred other people there at glance, which surprised him.

"I thought not many people dare to venture into the inner areas?" He asked Tian Suyin.

"Since this is just the border and the least dangerous area, many people risk their lives to come here, especially since the techniques they can learn in this place are at least Divine-rank."

"Is that so..."

Yuan didn't mind the mockery and acted as though they weren't even there.

"Anyways, now that we have arrived, I am going to study the swords. Yanyu, since this is a rare occasion, you should also try to learn something. We might not get another chance to come back here, after all." Tian Suyin said to her daughter.

"Okay." She nodded before turning to look at Yuan.

"What are you going to do?"

"Since I am here, I might as well look around, too." He said.

"Alright."

"Oh, how long do we plan on staying here?" Yuan suddenly asked.

"Since you wasted a month of our time, it's only fair if we stay here for a month. However, I guess two weeks will do." Tian Suyin said, as she didn't want to take away too much of Yuan's time, despite her words.

"I understand. Then we will leave in two weeks."

With that settled, Tian Suyin and Tian Yanyu immediately began wandering the Sword Graveyard. Like tombs in a graveyard, each sword had enough space between each other to allow people to surround it, so nobody there had to worry about fighting for spots.

With that being said, some swords are especially popular and do become overcrowded at times.

"Oh, lucky me! There's a spot left for the Silvermoon Soulblade!" Tian Suyin was filled with joy when she noticed an empty spot at one of the most

popular swords in the Sword Graveyard.

The Silvermoon Soulblade is a Mythic-grade sword— a treasure that normally wouldn't exist in the Third Heaven except for the Nameless Emperor's Tomb, so its popularity was only natural.

There were a total of 3 Mystic-grade swords in the Sword Graveyard, and they are usually packed to the brim with people, hence Tian Suyin's excitement.

Meanwhile, Tian Yanyu settled with a random Ancient-grade sword that caught her eyes the moment she looked at it, almost as though she had a connection with it.

"Radiant Scarlet Blade..." Tian Yanyu read the engraving on the sword's crimson blade.

As for Yuan, he merely stood at the entrance of the Sword Graveyard. There were so many swords that he didn't know where to start.

Eventually, he picked a random sword and sat before it.

"You guys can look around if you want." Yuan said to Xiao Hua and the others.

"I don't use the sword, so I am fine staying here." Lan Yingying said.

"Me too." Feng Yuxiang said.

"Xiao Hua will stay with you." Xiao Hua said.

Yuan didn't say anything else and returned to focusing on the sword before him.

'Let's see what kind of technique you'll teach me.' Yuan smiled inwardly.

He started by using Divine Gaze on the sword, but nothing special happened, so he just started studying it normally.

He would eventually enter a trance when images began appearing inside his mind. However, these images would not just teach him sword techniques.

In addition to sword techniques, they were memories— his memories with this particular sword. The moment of their meeting; their journeys together; all of the enemies they have slain together. These memories lasted all the way till the end of their journey.

Yuan was surprised at first, but he quickly calmed down and started to absorb these memories like a dry sponge with water. Since he'd grown accustomed to being fed memories, he found the process to be quite pleasing, as it was like watching a movie of himself.

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Chapter 1158 Memories Within The Sword Graveyard

Ten hours. Yuan had spent ten hours in real time recalling his memories with the sword, but inside his mind, dozens of years have passed.

He'd fought thousands of enemies, traveled tens of thousands of miles, and eventually had to put the sword to rest when it had become too damaged to use.

When Yuan snapped back into reality, he remained sitting there with a dazed look on his face, and tears were flowing down his cheeks.

"I remember now... I remember our time together... Starfall Saber." When Yuan uttered this familiar name, the sword before him suddenly began to tremble, almost as though it was responding to his call.

However, it calmed down a few seconds later. In the end, this Sword Graveyard and all of the swords within was nothing more than an illusion, something the masked man had created from his memories.

Despite that, the memories shown to Yuan by the sword were definitely very real.

"Are you okay, Brother Yuan?" Xiao Hua asked him.

"Yes, I am fine. We might actually stay here a little longer than expected," he said, as he'd decided to retrieve all of his memories from the swords in this place.

Sometime later, Yuan walked to the next sword. Since he was going to study all of them, he might as well start from the very first sword towards

the entrance of the graveyard.

Once he sat down before the sword that read 'Blood Moon Blade', Yuan would stare at the sword until his eyes slowly closed and images began appearing inside his head.

Over the next week, Yuan would spend anywhere between four hours to an entire day with each sword.

Thousands of years of experience and hundreds of unique sword techniques flooded Yuan's mind.

Even though he was just recalling his memories with the swords, his sword mastery would increase drastically without needing to lift a sword.

<Your understanding with the sword has improved significantly>

<Your understanding of swords has reached a new level>

<Your understanding with the sword has improved significantly>

<Your understanding of swords has reached a new level>

<Your understanding with the sword has improved significantly>

<Your understanding of swords has reached a new level>

At the end of the second week, Yuan looked at how many swords were left in the Sword Graveyard and sighed, "At this rate, it will take me years to go through every single sword here."

As Yuan pondered about what he should do in this situation, he suddenly heard a commotion not far away.

"Get out of my spot, you bitch!"

"Huh? What the hell are you talking about? Since when did this become your spot?"

Yuan raised an eyebrow upon hearing this familiar voice. He could see Tian Suyin arguing with another woman.

"Just now. A weak bitch like you should be grateful that you even got to study the Silvermoon Soulblade for a minute. I will not ask you again. Move, or I will move you myself!"

"You call me weak, yet you have a lower cultivation than me. How hilarious." Tian Suyin sneered in a cold manner.

The other woman laughed out loud, "You have no idea who you're messing with! Darling! Come get this bitch out of my spot!"

The following moment, Tian Suyin felt the pressure of a peak Spirit King bearing down on her.

Then, a figure descended from the sky and landed between them.

This figure stood well over seven feet tall and had a broad, muscular build with a thick neck, wide shoulders, and bulging arms and legs. His chest was as wide as a barrel, giving him an imposing appearance.

However, this man's staggering presence did not seem to faze Tian Suyin at all. In fact, she looked unimpressed.

"Really? You're going to make your man bully another woman? How pathetic are you?" Tian Suyin shook her head.

"Also, you're bothering the others."

"None of this would've happened if you were obedient. Now, we'll have to make a spectacle out of you. Anyways, it's too late even if you want to give up your seat now."

"..." Tian Suyin didn't say anything and started looking around the Sword Graveyard in silence.

"Are you going to act like a damsel in distress and ask for help? There's nobody here that can protect you." The woman laughed in an obnoxious

manner.

Meanwhile, when Tian Suyin noticed Yuan staring at them from a distance, a slight smile formed on her beautiful face.

"Even a damsel in distress has more dignity than someone like you. If you're going to do it, hurry up and do it, you pathetic little whore." Tian Suyin cursed back.

The woman trembled in anger, and she pointed at Tian Suyin before roaring, "Make her regret ever coming here, Wang Xuan!"

The bulky man's eyes became filled with killing intent as he retrieved a massive axe from his spatial ring and swung it at Tian Suyin.

The axe was also coated in a thin layer of Axe Aura, something similar to Sword Aura but only available to those who mastered the axe.

Tian Suyin's eyes widened slightly, but her vision was suddenly blocked by someone that had appeared in front of her like a ghost.

This person was obviously Yuan, and he lifted his arm to casually catch the incoming strike.

Whoosh!

A gust of wind swept the Sword Graveyard the moment Yuan caught the axe with just his fingers.

This shocked everybody there. As for the bulky man, he was in utter disbelief that someone had just caught his powerful attack with two mere fingers.

"You okay?" Yuan ignored the others and turned to ask Tian Suyin, who nodded her head in a dazed manner.

She knew that Yuan would protect her, but she didn't expect him to do it in such a fashion.

"Darling, what's wrong? Why did you stop? Just cleave through this fool who thinks he's a hero!" The woman misunderstood the situation and thought that the bulky man had stopped his attack right before his axe reached Yuan, as she thought that someone as small as Yuan in comparison could block the man's attack was simply impossible.

"T-That is..." The man didn't know how to respond, and he was still trying to comprehend the situation himself.

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Chapter 1159 Sword Graveyard's Fury

When the bulky man eventually realized the reality of his situation, his clothes became soaked in cold sweat.

'I cannot even pull away my axe from his grasp! What is happening?! How is he holding onto my axe that is coated with Axe Aura with his bare hands?!'

"Darling! What are you doing?! Hurry up and kill them!" His partner shouted again.

'Damn it! This dumb bitch has no idea the gravity of our situation!' The man cursed inwardly.

Yuan eventually released his grasp on the axe and lowered his hand.

"What should I do with them, Senior Tian?" Yuan asked her for suggestions.

"I don't care as long as you get rid of these eyesores," she said.

Yuan nodded and looked at the couple.

"Those who are prepared to take another's life should also be prepared to have theirs taken from them, right?" Yuan asked them.

"Aaaaargh!"

The bulky man that had been frozen for some time now suddenly roared like a wild beast. He lifted his axe and swung it again.

"Swift Execution!" The man's aura exploded, and the axe suddenly seemed ten times larger as it flew closer to Yuan and Tian Suyin.

'Let's see if this Sword Body is truly untouchable by weapon auras...' Yuan decided to just stand there without any thoughts of blocking the strike.

"This fool must be frozen with fear!" The woman laughed out loud when she saw him standing there like a statue.

Whoosh!

The massive axe that was aimed directly at Yuan's neck eventually reached its destination. However, forget about severing his head, the axe couldn't even cut his skin.

From the onlookers' eyes, the bulky man had, once again, stopped his axe right before it struck Yuan.

'I-I cannot cut him!' When the bulky man realized that Yuan didn't stop his first attack by mistake, he felt all of the strength in his body disappearing from his body.

This caused him to lose his grip on the axe, letting it fall into the ground. The bulky man then fell to his knees shortly after.

"Wang Xuan! What the fuck are you doing?!" The woman began cursing at him.

"Forget it! It was a mistake to rely on you! I will take care of them myself!"

The woman decided to take matters into her own hand and retrieved her weapon.

Now with a sword in her grasp, the woman rushed forward while performing a sword technique.

"..."

When the sword was close enough, Yuan closed his hand into a fist except for his middle finger.

He then casually lifted his arm, blocking the woman's sword with his middle finger.

"W-What...?" The woman's eyes nearly popped out of its sockets when she felt an immovable force colliding with her sword, her gaze glued to the single middle finger that was blocking her sword.

After blocking the attack, Yuan coated his middle finger with his Sword Aura, and like knife cutting tofu, his middle finger sliced through the Heaven-grade treasure without any resistance.

Thud.

The woman looked at the sword with a broken blade in her grasp with a baffled expression on her face. The spectators present shared similar reactions.

"This show-off..." Jin Xi muttered in a low voice after witnessing everything.

After a moment of dead silence, the woman suddenly turned to look at the Silvermoon Soulblade beside them.

Perhaps she had experienced such shock that her mind became roasted, but the woman was no longer thinking clearly.

In one swift movement, she extended her arm and grabbed onto the hilt of the sword.

When the cultivators around them saw this, their immediate reaction was to flee the area, and it wasn't just them.

"That crazy bitch touched the Silvermoon Soulblade! Run if you don't want to get caught up in her punishment!"

Every cultivator inside the Sword Graveyard quickly scrambled to get out of the graveyard.

"Huh?" The woman snapped back to reality after hearing such words, and she immediately released the sword.

The woman had barely touched the sword for a second, but it was already too late, as the sky above them quickly darkened.

Seeing this, Yuan grabbed Tian Suyin and pulled her away as he distanced himself from the couple.

The woman attempted to flee as well, but she remained still, as if bound by invisible shackles that rendered her utterly immobile, her very essence paralyzed by an unseen force beyond her comprehension.

A profound and eerie silence blanketed the graveyard, broken only by the faint rustle of wind through the trees, until suddenly, as if stirred by an otherworldly force, the thousands of swords resting within the graveyard began to tremble, their ancient blades resonating with a palpable and ominous energy that reverberated through the very air itself.

The swords stopped trembling after a few seconds before erupting from the ground and soaring into the heavens.

Astonished gasps could be heard from those that were witnessing this for the first time.

"H-Help! Someone! Please! Help me! I will do anything!" The woman began screaming her lungs out as her body was still frozen in time.

Unsurprisingly, nobody there even dared to take a step towards the graveyard at this moment.

A few seconds later, the swords hovering ominously in the air began to stir once more, their gleaming blades shifting in unison with an eerie grace, until they finally came to a stop with their sharp tips pointed at the terrified woman.

Despite the horrifying scene, nobody there could tear their gaze away from the scene, almost as though they were all trapped in a powerful charm. In the end, they all watched as the swords descended upon the woman and the man, covering their figures.

In that fleeting, heart-stopping moment, the very air itself seemed to come to a halt, suffocated by an all-encompassing dread that left a single soul present able to draw even the slightest breath.

And then, as suddenly as it had begun, the nightmare ended with the swords returning to their resting place, the graveyard once again peaceful.

As for the couple, not a trace remained, as if they never existed in the first place.

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Chapter 1160 The Sword Graveyard Trembles Again!

"Senior, I'd like to thank you again for stopping me before." Yuan mumbled in a dumbfounded voice after the Sword Graveyard's fury ended.

"..."

Tian Suyin was still in a state of shock, so she didn't hear him.

"I think that was our cue to leave. It's been two weeks, anyway." Tian Yanyu said.

"Oh, about that... I would actually like to stay a little longer." Yuan then said.

"Really? How long?" Tian Suyin immediately snapped out of her daze.

As terrifying as what had happened was, it wasn't enough to deter her from the Sword Graveyard, as she has yet to gain anything from it.

"I can't say for sure. How about another two weeks for now?" Yuan said after a moment of pondering.

Tian Suyin and her daughter agreed.

After their decision, they returned to the Sword Graveyard. The other cultivators also made their way back to their respective positions, but with a sense of unease grasping their heart. Their movements were stiff and careful, caused by a newfound hesitation and a growing apprehension of the unfathomable power that lay hidden within the swords.

Unsurprisingly, Tian Suyin returned to the Silvermoon Soulblade. The cultivators present with her purposefully distanced themselves from her, as they were also frightened of Yuan's presence.

Tian Suyin didn't complain since this gave her more breathing room, allowing her to focus more easily on the sword.

As for Tian Yanyu, she decided to try her luck on a new sword after two weeks of no progress from her previous sword, even going for a lower grade sword.

Yuan wanted to go back to studying the swords as well, but he has yet to resolve his problem regarding the lack of time in this place.

'Hmm... What should I do?' He continued to ponder but to no avail.

In the end, he decided to only study the swords that resonated with him the most.

The first sword was a mere Heaven-grade sword.

"Heavenly Ice Sword..."

Yuan mumbled its name as he sat before it.

The sword emitted a chilling aura, and as it brushed past him, Yuan felt a sudden, inexplicable shiver race down his spine.

Then, his earliest memories with this sword began appearing inside his head.

A woman stood before him. She was stunningly beautiful with a commanding presence that made her hard to ignore. She has sharp, angular features that gave her an almost sculpted appearance, and a cool, unapproachable demeanor that only adds to her allure.

Her eyes were piercing and seemed to have the ability to see through even Heaven itself, their light blue color perfectly complementing her pale,

flawless complexion. Her lips are full and perfectly shaped, but one glance and anyone could tell that she rarely smiled.

Despite her cool exterior, there was a sense of overwhelming strength to her gaze that suggested she was not someone to be trifled with, and in her grasp was the Heavenly Ice Sword.

"Why are you here?" The beauty asked him in a nonchalant voice.

"Your family is worried sick after your sudden disappearance, so they asked me to find you."

"Out of the millions of people they could've asked for help, they decided to ask for your help? I don't buy it."

Yuan chuckled, "If you don't believe me, you can go back to your family and ask them with me."

The beauty suddenly unsheathed her sword and pointed its cold blade at him.

"Do you take me for a fool?"

"I wouldn't dare."

"Hmph. If you want me to go back, defeat me."

"Are you sure?"

"I have always wanted to fight you, who is proclaimed as the number one genius by many."

"If you say so..."

Yuan retrieved his sword the very next moment.

'Ah... I know this sword... It was also in the Sword Graveyard.' He thought to himself as memories continued to flow inside his head.

Three hours later, Yuan slowly opened his eyes, muttering a name as he came to his senses, "Bingjie..."

After wiping the tears from his eyes, Yuan stood up and scanned the Sword Graveyard until he found a certain sword.

It was the sword he wielded when he clashed with the cold beauty.

"Red Dragon Fang."

Yuan quickly submerged himself in its memories.

In the blink of an eye, three weeks passed.

Even though they were supposed to leave a week ago, Tian Suyin and Tian Yanyu decided to stay longer when they noticed how engrossed Yuan was with the swords, and they were afraid to disturb his trance.

"I wonder what kind of techniques he is learning from them..." Tian Suyin's sigh carried a subtle hint of envy— a longing for something that seemed just out of her reach.

"I'm sure he'll tell us about it once he's done." Tian Yanyu smiled.

They returned to their own studies shortly after.

In the third week, after staying at the Sword Graveyard for a little over a month, Yuan received a notification.

<Your longing for a reunion has been heard by the spirits within the Sword Graveyard. Would you like to receive their response?>

Yuan was taken aback by this notification that felt different than usual.

"Yes, I do." He answered a moment later.

The very next second, the swords within the Sword Graveyard began to tremble once again, shocking the cultivators there.

"I-It's going to punish someone again!"

The trembling intensified as the cultivators began scrambling out of the area, and the swords soon began to glow with an otherworldly light, their blades pulsing with an energy that seemed to defy explanation. It was as if the swords themselves were alive, reacting to some unknown force that only they could sense.

Within seconds, all of the cultivators exited the Sword Graveyard— all but a single young man who stood at the center of the place with a nonchalant expression on his face.

"Xiao Yang?!" Tian Yanyu cried out loud at the sight of his lone figure in the graveyard, her heart beating so hard it was on the verge of bursting through her chest.

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Chapter 1161 Return The Swords Or Die!

When Tian Suyin noticed that her daughter was about to rush back into the Sword Graveyard, she quickly restricted her movements with a bear hug.

"Stop! Do you want to die?!"

"I don't care!"

"He's not going to die— I think!" Tian Suyin suddenly exclaimed, which calmed Tian Yanyu down a little.

"Look at it— feel the atmosphere. Despite the similarities, this is nothing like when that couple got punished, and as crazy as this may sound, I can feel a sense of attachment from the swords. "

As the spectators awaited yet another grand display of execution, the blades buried within the Sword Graveyard awakened from their slumber once again, ascending to the heavens in a breathtaking dance.

Once every sword ascended to the sky, they began to move in perfect harmony, their razor-sharp tips converging towards Yuan, who stood firmly and unhinged despite the terrifying scene happening above him.

However, the ladies inside Yuan did not share the same feeling. In fact, they were terrified for him.

"Young Master... I think this is a little too dangerous even for you..."

"Brother Yuan..."

"..."

"Don't worry, they won't hurt me. I can feel it." Yuan said to them with an air of tranquility enveloping his words, trying to calm their souls with his overwhelming confidence.

"Come!" He suddenly roared.

The swords suspended in the sky immediately stirred with a mighty force and hurled towards Yuan like a celestial barrage of fiery meteors.

However, when the first sword reached Yuan and pierced his body, it did not go through his body and come out the other end like it was supposed to and actually disappeared into his body.

The second sword and the swords after that also did the same thing, and it was as though they were being absorbed by him. This continued until there was not a single sword left.

Everything happened so fast that the onlookers were still trying to figure out what they had just witnessed even many minutes later.

After the swords entered his body, Yuan quickly realized that he could retrieve their memories at will.

'Does this mean I no longer need to stay here to recall their memories one by one? This is great!' Yuan was filled with excitement knowing that he could take his time absorbing these memories.

Sometime later, the cultivators outside the Sword Graveyard made their way back into the area, and they all had deep frowns on their faces.

"Hey! What did you do with the swords?! Why are they not returning?!" One of them pointed at Yuan and questioned him about the swords, as they have yet to return.

Without any swords, the Sword Graveyard could no longer bear such a name. In fact, it wouldn't even qualify as an ordinary graveyard, as there were only holes in the ground which had been left behind by the swords.

"No idea." Yuan answered with a calm shrug.

"A-Are you fucking with me?! Bring back the swords!"

"Yeah! Or we will tear your body open and take them back by force!"

The cultivators began threatening Yuan with force. Although none of them were confident of defeating Yuan alone, they felt invincible together.

There were a little over 200 cultivators present. They believed that if they all attacked at once, not even he would leave unscathed.

"I really don't know what happened to the swords, nor can I take them out since I don't have them!" Yuan sighed.

"Bullshit! Everyone here watched you absorb the swords into your body!"

"I know that's what it looked like, but..."

"Fuck it! This bastard is clearly not going to comply! Let's get him!"

Before Yuan could even finish his sentence, the cultivators encircled him, exuding an aura of animosity, their eyes fixed upon him with killing intent.

"I really don't want to hurt anyone here over something nobody here could control... Let's try to settle this peacefully, alright?"

Yuan felt a little guilty for hogging all of the swords for himself and inconveniencing these people, even if he had a good reason for doing so.

"If you want this to end peacefully, you will return those swords!" Someone shouted.

"Yeah! That's right! Return the swords! They belong to nobody but the Nameless Emperor's Tomb, much less a nobody like you!"

In the midst of the chaos, Yuan had a sudden idea flash inside his head.

"How about this? I will give everyone here a chance to learn a sword technique of their choosing. These sword techniques will come from the swords that had existed within the Sword Graveyard."

"What kind of nonsense is that?!"

"Do you think we are idiots?!"

"Let me explain!" Yuan quickly said.

"When the swords entered my body, I learned all of their sword techniques, and I am willing to show them to you. Even if I return the swords, what are the chances of you actually learning its technique?" Yuan spoke to these cultivators with logic and reasoning.

"Y-You learned all of the sword techniques?!" The cultivators were shocked, but they did not immediately believe Yuan's words either, as it sounded too good to be true.

"That's impossible! He's definitely lying to us to save his own life!"

"Right?! I'm willing to bet my life that he doesn't know shit!"

The cultivators quickly became hostile again.

"What should we do...?" Tian Yanyu asked her mother as they watched from a distance.

"Nothing. He can handle it himself." Tian Suyin said with an unwavering expression on her face.

Seeing that nobody would believe him, Yuan decided to approach this situation from another direction, but he still wasn't planning on taking any lives.

He spread his arms wide open and gestured for them in a provoking manner. "Alright. You know what? If you think you can kill me, go ahead. I won't fight back for the first ten minutes. But after ten minutes, I will retaliate."

Yuan's words that belittled the gathered cultivators ignited a furious outburst, causing them to unleash their fangs upon his neck. Unperturbed, Yuan merely stood his ground with his hands in his pockets as all sorts of weapons struck his body with no results, his presence becoming more menacing as the ten minutes counted down.

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Chapter 1162 Ten Minute Countdown

Clang! Clang! Clang!

The sound of metal colliding with each other resounded without stopping as over a hundred cultivators tried to cut Yuan's body.

However, no matter how much strength they put in their swings, nobody there could scratch his skin, much less make him bleed.

"How is this possible?! What kind of trick is he using to block our attacks?!"

The cultivators refused to believe that Yuan had an invincible body.

"Tick tock, tick tock, tick tock. You have seven minutes before I make my move." Yuan would provoke them with a menacing smile on his face every minute, reminding them of their impending doom.

Of course, this made the cultivators even more intense.

"Your body may be untouchable, but what about your eyes?!" A woman suddenly propelled herself forward with fierceness, wielding a slender, razor-sharp sword, aimed with deadly precision at Yuan's very sight.

But alas, just like the rest of his body, her sword could not penetrate his eyes.

"Let's try spiritual attacks! There's no way he cultivated both his body and mind to the same degree!" Someone there suddenly suggested.

However, since techniques that directly attacked one's spirit were incredibly rare, nobody there actually knew of any. This was why nobody tried it in the first place.

"Nobody here knows any spiritual attacks?! Damn it!"

"A-Actually, I know one, but it's not really meant to do any damage..."
Someone there suddenly said.

"I don't care! If it has a chance to break his defenses, use it!"

"Alright."

A beauty with long black hair came forward and stood before Yuan, who continued to stand there in an unfazed manner.

She looked at him with raised eyebrows, feeling a little awkward, as she has never gotten the chance to use this technique without retaliation from the other party.

After taking a deep breath, she lifted both her arms and made several hand gestures while facing them at Yuan.

"Spiritual Constriction Art!"

Yuan immediately felt an unforce entering his mind. However, due to his immense soul strength that was incomparably stronger than the woman, it was destroyed just as quickly as it entered his mind.

A moment of silence later, when Yuan showed no reaction, the woman mumbled, "I think it worked."

"Really? What was it supposed to do?" Yuan suddenly asked, startling the woman to the point it made her jump back like a scared kitten.

"I-It didn't work!" She quickly corrected herself.

"Anyways, you have five minutes left. Or should I just save some time and kill all of you now, since it's clear that nobody here can kill me."

The cultivators there immediately became defensive after hearing his words with some of them even running away.

Yuan laughed at their reaction.

"Or I can spare your lives. However, since you all refused my offer in the beginning, I will no longer teach you guys any technique."

"With that being said, if you are willing to accept my challenge and survive one of my strikes, I will give you a chance to learn a technique."

The cultivators there looked at each other, wondering what they would do in this situation. Should they risk their life, or should they just leave?

"You have three minutes to decide before I kill everyone that is still here." Yuan reminded them that the timer was still counting down. Of course, he had no real intentions of killing them and just wanted to mess with them.

"I-I am willing to accept the challenge!" A short man stepped forward with a resolute expression on his face.

Since he risked his life to come this far without any guarantees that he'd gain anything from the Sword Graveyard, he might as well risk his life again for this.

"Very well. And don't expect me to go easy on you." Yuan said.

The others quickly gave them some space.

"I will move in exactly 10 seconds from now. Try your best to stay alive."

The man swallowed nervously.

And as he stood there, every passing second felt like an eternity, as if time itself had come to a standstill.

When the appointed moment finally arrived, Yuan swiftly drew forth his sword with a graceful and fluid motion, his sword emanating an aura of

immense power that surged forth in a wave of unfettered Sword Aura, aimed at the man.

It was at this moment that the man regretted his decision, but it was too late to back down.

"AAAAAAHHHH!" The man released a beastly roar as all of the strength in his body gushed forward like a broken dam, his life depending on it to block Yuan's Sword Aura.

When the man's sword clashed with Yuan's Sword Aura, he immediately realized the difference in their strength. It was like heaven and earth, and he felt like a mortal before an unattainable strength that will forever haunt his soul.

With their clash, the man's sword was cleanly sliced in two by the Sword Aura, leaving him defenseless before the unstoppable force.

The Sword Aura continued its unrelenting advance, cleaving through the air with a fearsome intensity until it made contact with the man's chest, carving a deep and lasting scar into his flesh.

In that moment, the man was brought to the brink of death, his very essence laid bare before the merciless might of Yuan's Sword Aura.

The onlookers swallowed nervously after witnessing the scene.

The spectacle before them was not a showcase of Yuan's sword techniques, but a display of his raw power that was channeled through his Sword Aura.

However, unbeknownst to them, that wasn't even half of Yuan's full strength, as he'd held back just enough so that he wouldn't kill his challenger.

Yuan turned to look at the crowd and asked them, "Anyone got a restoration pill for him? He might really die at this rate."

Someone quickly came forward to offer a mid-quality restoration pill.

Once consumed, the man's bleeding immediately stopped and his breathing became steady, but the scar on his chest remained.

"Since you managed to survive, I will teach you a sword technique from any sword that existed within the Sword Graveyard, but seeing your current condition, let's postpone this until I go through everyone else here."

"Okay..." The man nodded in a stiff movement.

Yuan turned to look at the others with a devil-like smile, "So, who else wants to challenge me?"

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Chapter 1163 Unfathomable Generosity

The cultivators at the Sword Graveyard silently stared at the man lying on the ground with a massive scar on his chest. Fortunately, he barely managed to survive.

However, they might not be as lucky, and judging from what they witnessed, nobody there was confident in blocking Yuan's Sword Aura.

'I will probably die if I am struck by his Sword Aura.' Many of the cultivators there had the same thought.

"If you do not wish to challenge me, you may leave and I will not chase after you. However, if you stay here, I will come for you." Yuan said.

And he continued, "One minute left."

Over half of the cultivators there turned around and ran away. They did not want to be chased by a monster that could not be harmed even by Heaven-grade treasures.

In their eyes, Yuan was even more dangerous than the immortal demons that roamed this land.

Once those that wanted to leave were gone, Yuan beckoned those that decided to stay.

"We don't have all day. Come receive my strike if you dare."

His next challenger stepped forward with trembling legs.

'If a man like that had the courage to receive his strike, there's no reason I should run away!' This man encouraged himself using the first challenger.

As they assumed their position, Yuan slashed forward, sending his Sword Aura at the man.

"It's gotten even stronger!"

The onlookers exclaimed in a shocked voice after sensing the devastating pressure coming from Yuan's sword.

Naturally, Yuan had adjusted his strength to his new challenger, or it wouldn't be fair to the previous one.

"Argh!"

The man screamed in pain as the Sword Aura cleanly sliced through his defensive treasure and two of his fingers.

He then retrieved multiple restoration pills and swallowed all of them at once, bloating his throat like a toad.

"I-I have survived!" The man roared in excitement and relief.

Yuan didn't watch him celebrate and immediately beckoned for the next challenger.

Over the next hour, Yuan would unleash his Sword Aura again and again upon those that dared to challenge him. In the end, none of the hundred or so cultivators that challenged him managed to escape unscathed with many receiving life-threatening injuries. Some of them were even missing a limb or two.

And unfortunately, despite his best efforts to control his power and minimize the damage, Yuan could not do anything about any unforeseen accidents, which tragically ended the lives of several challengers, their corpses turning into spiritual energy for the Endless Emperor's Tomb.

After a moment of silence for those that died, Yuan began to fulfill his promise to those that managed to survive.

"Which sword do you wish to learn from?" He asked the man who now had a scar on his chest.

"I want to learn the Divine Edge's technique!"

"Very well." Yuan immediately used technique transfer to send the technique directly into the man's head.

When he absorbed the swords within the Sword Graveyard, he immediately learned all of their techniques. However, their memories still required him to manually absorb them.

"T-This is the Divine Edge's sword technique...?" The man muttered in a dazed voice after acquiring the sword technique.

"Yes, but allow me to give you some disclaimers. Even if I transfer the technique to you, it is not guaranteed that you will comprehend it. Furthermore, it will disappear from your memories after a full year passes, and you won't be able to extract this technique from your mind even if you tried. Understand?"

"I understand..." The man nodded his head in a dazed manner.

Once he confirmed that the technique was inside his head, he wasted no time leaving the Sword Graveyard to find a safe place to study the technique.

Yuan continued to transfer sword techniques to the cultivators there.

Unsurprisingly, the most popular choice of technique was those from the three Mythic-grade swords.

Once Yuan finished handing out the techniques, the place became completely empty. The holes left behind by the swords also disappeared, leaving behind no evidence that the Sword Graveyard ever existed.

"When will you stop erasing historical sites from the Nameless Emperor's Tomb? Those who want to visit the Sword Graveyard after this will forever be unable to fulfill their dream." Tian Suyin sighed, and she felt bad for those cultivators that intended on visiting the place like her someday.

She turned to look at the now desolate land and sighed once again, "I already knew that I wouldn't get another chance to come back to this place, but to think it wouldn't be due to my lack of strength but because the place no longer exists..."

Yuan smiled, "There's no need to come back here if you learn every sword technique that existed in this place."

Tian Suyin snapped at his remarks, "Are you rubbing it in my face on purpose?! You think everyone is as lucky as you?!"

"No, I was simply implying that I am willing to teach you the techniques."

"Eh?" The angry expression on Tian Suyin's face immediately froze as she tried to process what Yuan had just said.

"Say that again for me. I don't think I heard you properly."

Yuan chuckled, "Do you want me to give you all of the sword techniques that I acquired from this place?"

"A-Are you serious? You're not messing with me, right?" Tian Suyin's body trembled uncontrollably.

Yuan silently extended his hand and smiled.

Tian Suyin, still in disbelief, slowly placed her soft hand on top of Yuan's palm.

The following moment, Tian Suyin's mind was flooded with hundreds of powerful sword techniques ranging from Heaven-rank to Ancient-rank.

"There's going to be almost no restriction for you, Senior Tian, so you can take as much time as you need to study these sword techniques. If you wish

to pass down these techniques, you may do so as well. The only restriction that I cannot control would be your ability to actually learn these techniques." Yuan said to her.

"This is... You... I..." Tian Suyin was utterly speechless, and she was beginning to genuinely feel guilty about treating him like a bad person with ulterior motives this entire time.

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Chapter 1164 Jin Xi's Authority

Yuan turned to look at Tian Yanyu after giving her mother the sword techniques.

"Give me your hand. I will also pass down these techniques to you," he said still with a smile on his face.

"But why...? Why are you doing so much for us when we were strangers until not long ago?" Tian Suyin asked him in a low voice.

Yuan sighed, "I want to tell you the truth, but for your safety, I cannot do so. However, please trust me when I say that I have no ulterior motives and simply want to help the Tian Family."

"You don't have to say anything else, Xiao Yang." Tian Yanyu mumbled as she placed her hand on his palm.

"Your actions have long proven to me that you're not here to harm us, so you don't need to say another word regarding that, as I trust you with my whole being."

Tian Yanyu's face was visibly crimson red at this moment.

Yuan smiled at her words as he transferred the sword techniques to her.

"Just like Senior Tian, the only restriction is your ability to comprehend these techniques."

"Thank you, Xiao Yang... Truly, thank you."

Yuan nodded, "I will be heading deeper into the tomb now. What will the two of you do?"

"Mother?" Tian Yanyu turned to look at her.

"I would like to say that we should regroup with the sect, but we have already received enough from this place. In fact, I doubt there is anyone—besides Xiao Yang—who has received more than us from the tomb. There's no need for us to risk our lives here anymore. Let's leave."

Tian Yanyu nodded, agreeing with her mother's decision to leave the tomb.

"Alright. Then I will see you guys later." Yuan said to them before turning to look at Jin Xi, who had been in the background this entire time.

"Jin Xi, can I trouble you one last time to guide them out of this tomb safely?" He asked her with clasped hands and his head lowered.

Jin Xi did not respond to him and turned to look at the two ladies.

"Can you confirm that you wish to leave this place entirely?" She asked them.

"Yes." Tian Suyin nodded, as did Tian Yanyu.

"Done."

Jin Xi suddenly snapped her fingers, and Tian Suyin and Tian Yanyu's figure disappeared into thin air, almost as if Jin Xi had snapped them out of existence.

"What did you do to them?" Yuan asked her with a slight frown on his face.

"I forcefully teleported them out of here, exactly what they wanted," she calmly said.

"You have such powers?" Yuan was surprised to learn this information.

"Do not underestimate my authority within this place," she sneered in a boastful manner.

"By the way, don't forget to grab the key."

Jin Xi pointed at a certain area, where a blue key was stabbed into the ground.

After realizing this, Yuan used Qi Manifestation to grab the key from afar.

"Alright, where to next?" He turned to look at Jin Xi.

"Why are you asking me?" She raised an eyebrow.

"Isn't that your job as a guide? To guide me around?" He asked.

"That does not mean I will be holding your hands and taking you on a stroll."

"So you're basically useless..." Yuan sighed.

"Huh?! What did you just call me?!"

"Nothing. Since there's almost no information about the inner areas, I guess I will just have to wander around and hope that I run into something."

He proceeded to pick a random direction that wasn't towards where he'd come from and started flying that way.

"I dare you to call me useless again! I dare you!" Jin Xi complained as she followed him from behind.

'Even though she's probably Li Jinxi's incarnation, there's a vast difference between their characters.' Yuan thought to himself as he tried his best to ignore her.

A week later.

"Kill him! Kill him! Kill him!" A demon wearing a black-colored crystal on its right shoulder roared as it commanded the surrounding demons with a red crystal.

Over 10 demons rushed at Yuan simultaneously.

"What's wrong? You seem to be having trouble with a mere human! Are you not ashamed to be called a demon?!" Yuan provoked them as he killed them one at a time with Sword Aura.

There were over 50 demons when the fight started, but there are less than 10 now. This caused the other demons to panic, especially the Elite Demon, who was in control of the group.

"How can a mere human kill us so easily?! He's not even using demon sealing techniques!" The Elite Demon gritted its teeth from frustration.

"You want me to use demon sealing techniques on fake demons? Even smashing an egg with a mountain is less wasteful than that!"

"How dare a mere livestock mock me?! An Elite Demon?!"

The Elite Demon eventually joined the other demons in the fight, but alas, its presence in the battle did not affect the results even in the slightest.

After killing the last demon, Yuan sighed in a regretful tone, "It's a true pity that they don't leave behind their crystal in here."

"At any rate, there's a lot of demons in this place. Why is that?" He wondered out loud, as he encountered more demons than magical beasts.

"That's simple. Humans are more terrified of demons than magical beasts, and they are also harder to deal with. The inner area isn't meant for ordinary cultivators, and even top geniuses have a hard time traversing this place."

"Is that so? Then what about the core area? Does it actually exist?"

"Yes, it exists, but that place isn't meant for anyone, period. Despite that, three people have made it to the core."

"Oh? Who?" Yuan asked with great interest.

"A dragon, a phoenix, and a human."

"That's it? At least give me a little more information."

She shook her head and said, "Too bad, because that's all I know."

"Is that so? They must all be famous individuals in the upper heavens, given that they have enough talent to reach the core..." Yuan mumbled.

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Chapter 1165 Mysterious Garden

"If you care so much about it, why don't you go take a look at their sites? Maybe you'll learn something about their identities." Jin Xi suddenly said.

"Their sites? What are you talking about?" Yuan raised an eyebrow.

"Those that have managed to make it to the core of the tomb are awarded with a special location somewhere in the tomb to memorize them. If you make it to the core, the tomb will also create a unique place for you."

"Although they pique my interest, I am not going to go out of my way to see these places, unless they benefit me somehow."

"Nope, you don't get anything from visiting these places."

Sometime later, Yuan came to a halt when he noticed a colossal shadow looming in the distance, its shape and form reminiscent that of a dragon.

"Hey, is that..."

"Indeed, that statue was created to memorialize the dragon who reached the core. It's quite large, spanning thousands of miles."

Despite only seeing a glimpse of its immense form, Yuan couldn't shake the inexplicable feeling of familiarity that washed over him at the sight of the shadow. It was as if he had encountered this behemoth before, perhaps in a long-forgotten dream or a faded memory from a past life, and its presence now stirred something deep within him, something primal and profound that defied explanation.

"The Great One...?" Yuan suddenly muttered this name.

"Hm? You know the dragon?" Jin Xi looked at him with a surprised look on her face.

"I'm not sure if this dragon is the Great One. It certainly gives me a familiar vibe. Though, even if it is the Great One, I can't say that I really know him. It's complicated."

After encountering what he assumes to be the Great One, Yuan decided to follow the direction it was pointed towards.

Thousands of miles later, Yuan came to a stop again when he noticed a garden in the distance.

"What is this place?" Yuan asked Jin Xi as he descended towards it.

However, Jin Xi didn't respond, and when he turned to look at her, she appeared to be greatly shocked by the appearance of this garden.

"W-Why is this place here...?"

He could hear Jin Xi mumbling in a dazed voice.

Yuan raised an eyebrow and returned to look at the garden from outside.

At glance, he couldn't help but be awestruck by the vast array of colorful and vibrant blooms inside the garden, each one a unique and exquisite creation of nature's boundless beauty, captivating his senses and filling his soul with a sense of wonder. However, these flowers were clearly still immature and not fully bloomed.

At the heart of the garden, amidst the colorful flowers, stood a small and unassuming pavilion. When Yuan's eyes beheld the sight of the pavilion, his heart stirred with an inexplicable yearning, a deep connection that transcended time and space.

As if drawn by an invisible force, he felt compelled to approach it, his footsteps guided by an ethereal presence that whispered to his soul, beckoning him to get closer.

The pavilion, bathed in the soft light of the sun, seemed to glow with an otherworldly radiance.

When Yuan stepped foot inside the garden, a curious thing happened.

The flowers that had been half-bloomed, began to stir, as if sensing his presence and responding to his arrival.

Petals unfurled, leaves stretched out to bask in the sunlight, and the air was filled with the sweet fragrance of blossoms bursting into full bloom.

It was as if the garden had been waiting for him, ready to showcase its most precious treasures in his honor.

Yuan felt a surge of wonder and awe wash over him, as if he had stumbled upon a secret garden that had been hidden away from the world for countless eras, now revealed to him alone.

The flowers fully bloomed by the time he reached the pavilion, and to his absolute surprise, these flowers became enveloped in Sword Aura after their blossoming.

Since there was nothing inside the pavilion, Yuan could only stand there and look around as he tried to figure out the secrets of this garden.

He used Divine Gaze when he saw nothing with Divine Sense, but even then, he wasn't able to see anything special about this place besides the flowers with Sword Aura.

He turned to look at Jin Xi and asked in a loud voice, "Hey! Jin Xi! What is this place?"

Jin Xi snapped out of her daze and looked at him with a pondering face.

"No... There's no way..." She mumbled in a dumbfounded voice.

Eventually, she said, "There is nothing special about this garden, so you can stop wasting your time here."

Yuan immediately doubted her words, which did not align with her reaction.

When Jin Xi saw the dubious look on his face, she sneered, "I am serious. There isn't anything for you to gain here. It's just a garden that was once managed by my Master. If you don't believe me, you can continue wasting your time here."

Yuan stared at her eyes to see if she was teasing him or if she was telling the truth.

'She's not lying... But why would a pointless place like this exist in the tomb?' He wondered inwardly.

'Whatever, I will come back here later if I have the time.'

With that in mind, Yuan left the garden and returned to wandering the tomb.

Jin Xi silently stared at Yuan's back and thought to herself, 'That garden only blooms for Master, so why did it bloom for him?'

As they soared through the sky, leaving the garden behind, a strange phenomenon began to unfold. A thick mist, like a shroud of mystery, descended upon the garden, obscuring it from view and engulfing it in a cloak of otherworldly fog.

When the mist finally dissipated, there was nothing left but an empty patch of ground, devoid of any sign that a garden had ever existed there. It was as if the garden had been a mirage, a fleeting dream that had vanished into the ether as soon as it had been beheld.

Chapter 1166 Phoenix Statue

After flying for several more days, Yuan came to a halt when another statue appeared in the distance. This time, it was that of a massive phoenix with colossal wings that covered almost the entire sky.

"What a sight..." Yuan took a deep breath after a sense of awe washed over him.

Suddenly, a figure materialized right in front of him out of thin air.

It was Feng Yuxiang, and she was staring at the phoenix with a dazed look on her face.

"Feng Feng? Are you feeling okay?" He asked her.

"Yes... It's just that when I look at this statue, my blood suddenly starts to boil for some reason, almost as though it's reacting to it."

"Perhaps you recognize this phoenix?" Yuan made a guess.

"That's possible, but I don't remember seeing this phoenix before," she sighed.

Yuan narrowed his eyes at the phoenix and asked, "You can tell? Even though it's just a statue?"

He would have a hard time telling the difference between two phoenixes unless one had a unique feature.

"It's just a feeling. I am not certain that I know this phoenix, but I cannot ignore my body's reaction. This is the first time something like this has happened to me."

Yuan then said, "Go ahead, take a closer look. I will wait for you."

"Thank you, Young Master."

Feng Yuxiang nodded and flew closer to the phoenix.

After spending several minutes inspecting the phoenix statue, Feng Yuxiang returned to Yuan's side and said, "That is a mature phoenix— a female one, at that."

"Oh... How can you tell the difference between a male and female phoenix?" Yuan asked out of curiosity.

Feng Yuxiang smiled and said, "The chest. You see how her chest is slightly puffed out? A male phoenix's chest is much flatter."

"Is that so..."

"Anyways, I am done here. Maybe I met this phoenix in the past and forgot about it, but there's no point pondering about it now."

He nodded, "Alright. Let's continue moving then."

This time, he decided to move towards the direction the phoenix was pointing.

Two days later, Yuan came to another halt when he was suddenly surrounded by demons.

This time, there were over a hundred of them. The majority of them were low-ranking demons, but there were a dozen Elite Demons, three Superior Demons, and one Demon General.

"A whole army of demons this time, huh." Yuan mumbled with a nonchalant look on his face.

Since he was facing this many demons at once, he could no longer go easy on them. Thus, he decided to use one demon sealing technique— just one.

His eyes flickered with a vicious glint before activating the Demon Sealing Zone.

Whoosh!

The Demon Sealing Zone instantly swallowed up all of the demons, and the moment it touched a demon, they would immediately turn into solid, becoming a statue.

Jin Xi's eyes widened when she saw this. In her eyes, all of the demons there simultaneously turned into stone out of the blue.

"You... You are a Demon Sealer, as well?" She asked him in a dumbfounded voice.

"That's right." He calmly nodded.

"Why did you hide it until now?" She raised an eyebrow.

"I wasn't trying to hide it. I just didn't need to use it. My Sword Aura is more than enough to deal with a few demons." He shrugged.

"Unbelievable..."

"Anyways, I am going to try something new. You should move away, since this is going to cover a large area."

Jin Xi suddenly stuck out her chest and puffed in an arrogant manner, "You won't be able to hurt me even if you tried. My strength was limited during the trial for your sake, but I no longer have said limit."

"If you say so..." Yuan proceeded to close his eyes and began building up his Sword Aura.

A minute or so later, his eyes snapped open, and a massive amount of Sword Aura gushed out of his body. However, it did not stop and continued to expand until it was large enough to kill all of the demons there in one fell swoop.

Yuan released a sigh afterward.

"Although that worked, it took too long. I will need to work on my speed before I can actually use it properly."

Lan Yingying then said, "And if you can make it last longer, you will be able to use it to protect cities, just like the Lord did in the Mystic Realm."

"Oh, you're right. It's basically the same thing." Yuan said after realizing this.

Right before they continued their journey, Jin Xi reminded Yuan that the Demon General had left behind a crimson key.

"This makes it the fifth key in my possession. I still need four more, huh." Yuan did not like this easter egg hunt at all.

A few more days later, Yuan noticed a small pond about a hundred miles away, and despite being that far away, he could sense a strong Sword Aura coming from it.

"What is this place?" Yuan asked Jin Xi once they landed before it.

"Sword Pond is its name."

Yuan tried to see how deep this pond was, but to his absolute shock, he wasn't able to see the ground even with his Divine Sense at maximum strength.

"Heavens... How far down does this pond go?" He turned to look at Jin Xi with a stupefied face.

She shrugged, "Who knows. Why don't you go down there and let me know afterward?"

Yuan was not the least surprised by her response, even expecting it.

He turned to look at the pond and swallowed nervously.

Despite its calm appearances, every drop of water in this pond was covered by a thin layer of Sword Aura. If an ordinary cultivator plunged into this water, their body would instantly get shredded until there was nothing left, and this pond was deep— at least a thousand miles deep.

Unfortunately, Yuan knew that he was fated to enter this pond. He only prayed that he wouldn't instantly die the moment he entered it.

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Chapter 1167 Sword Pond

"Alright, I am going to enter this pond since I have a good feeling that I will find a key at the end— no, I am certain." Yuan said with a resolute expression on his face.

"Is that so? Have fun." Jin Xi said in a nonchalant manner, almost as if she couldn't care less.

Yuan didn't say anything and started stripping his clothes.

However, just as he took two steps towards the pond and prepared to plunge inside, his movements suddenly halted.

"What are you doing?" Jin Xi asked after seeing his weird movements.

"..."

After a moment of awkward silence, he said in a somewhat embarrassed voice, "I... I don't know how to swim."

"..."

Jin Xi's eyes widened as she stared at him in silence.

A moment later, she bent backwards and started laughing out loud that her voice could be heard miles away.

"Are you serious?! You don't know how to swim?! That's pathetic!" She pointed at him and laughed without restraint.

Yuan frowned and said, "Due to circumstances, my movements were limited until recently, so I did not have the opportunity to learn how to

swim. Is it really so bad that one doesn't know how to swim?"

"Yeah, yeah. No need for excuses. That'll just make you look even more pathetic."

Yuan sighed, but he decided to not argue with her.

Jin Xi suddenly snapped her fingers, creating a massive hole right next to the Sword Pond, and with a second snap, she filled the hole with clear water.

"You can practice swimming there. Just don't waste too much time." Jin Xi said to him. Despite making fun of him for not being able to swim, she still wanted to help him.

Feng Yuxiang and the others came out of his body watch.

"Young Master, I would love to teach you how to swim, but honestly, I don't know how to myself, and I do not like water." Feng Yuxiang sighed.

"Well, you are a creature of fire, after all." Yuan smiled at her.

Xiao Hua looked at the water for a second before turning to look at Yuan and shaking her head, "Sorry, Brother Yuan, but Xiao Hua cannot help you today."

"You're still young, so it's okay..."

Yuan subconsciously turned to look at Lan Yingying next, who had a gentle smile on her face.

"I guess you also don't know how to swim," he sighed.

"No, I do. I can teach you, if you'd like."

Yuan was so happy to hear that Lan Yingying knew how to swim, it caused him to shed a tear.

Lan Yingying proceeded to remove her clothes the following second.

"Y-You! How dare you try to seduce the Young Master with your body in this kind of situation!" Feng Yuxiang pointed at her with trembling fingers when Lan Yingying stripped completely naked.

"What are you talking about?" Lan Yingying looked at her with raised eyebrows, oblivious of the situation.

"Why are you completely naked?!" Feng Yuxiang asked again.

Lan Yingying immediately responded in an innocent voice, "Because I am going in the water with him?"

Feng Yuxiang facepalmed. "Is she messing with me, or is she actually that shameless?"

"If you are worried about me being seen naked, you don't have to worry. I don't mind if it's Yuan, and this isn't our first time like this."

"W-What did you say?!" Feng Yuxiang exclaimed, as she wasn't aware of their interaction at the waterfall within the Mystic Realm, where Lan Yingying was impregnated by Yuan.

Lan Yingying stopped entertaining Feng Yuxiang afterward and entered the cool water, which was about 2 meters deep.

After entering the water, Lan Yingying waited for Yuan at the edge of the pond.

Seeing Lan Yingying's beautiful naked body, Yuan couldn't help but swallow nervously.

Unlike previously when they were at the waterfall, he was no longer as ignorant and immune to a woman's charm, and his opponent was a peerless beauty like Lan Yingying, so his body couldn't help but react a little.

However, Yuan quickly managed to keep his emotions under control by reminding himself that underneath her human appearance was a Divine Beast that could swallow even demons, and most importantly, she was his comrade.

After patting himself in the cheeks, Yuan entered the water, grabbing Lan Yingying's hand at the same time so that he wouldn't immediately sink.

Although he could technically cover himself in spiritual energy and fly around in water, he actually wanted to use this opportunity to learn something that he never got the chance to.

Thus, Lan Yingying started giving Yuan swimming lessons.

Their training would go on for a few days until Yuan could swim as naturally as breathing.

"It took you longer than I expected, since you usually learn everything in a heartbeat." Feng Yuxiang said to him afterward.

"I guess there are some things that even I am not talented in." He chuckled.

"Thank you, Yingying. I've troubled you for the last few days." He said to her afterward.

"It was a pleasure to finally be able to help you." She smiled at him before pulling herself out of the water.

Yuan quickly shifted his gaze from her dripping wet body to something else.

'Hm?' Feng Yuxiang raised an eyebrow after seeing his unusual reaction, but she didn't think too much of it at that moment.

Now that he was prepared, Yuan returned to the Sword Pond, but he didn't immediately jump in.

He sat down and cultivated for a bit first.

A few hours later, Yuan opened his eyes and stood up.

After taking a deep breath, he leaped into the air before diving into the Sword Pond.

'Since it's just Sword Aura, it shouldn't affect my Sword Body.' He thought to himself as he plunged into the cold water.

'Fuck! It's freezing!' He cursed inwardly, and he regretted not testing the water's temperature before jumping in.

The water was so cold it felt like every pore in his body was being poked by needles.

Fortunately, he was used to pain from tempering his body, so it was still tolerable for him.

Unfortunately, the cold would only worsen as he swam deeper inside the Sword Pond.

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Chapter 1168 Sword Pond(2)

After swimming for a minute, Yuan immediately gave up on trying to swim normally and propelled himself forward using spiritual energy.

Not only did this help him travel many times faster but it also protected him from the cold. However, because every drop of water in the Sword Pond is covered in Sword Aura, it would shred his spiritual energy constantly.

Fortunately, he could recover his spiritual energy faster than the Sword Aura destroyed it.

About a hundred miles down, the temperature in the Sword Pond changed drastically.

It was no longer cold, but scorching hot, almost as though he was swimming in lava, and it burned through his spiritual energy like a hot knife in butter.

This sudden change in temperatures caught Yuan off guard, and he had to quickly adjust to it.

The temperature was so hot that it constantly burned his skin. If it weren't for his regeneration ability, he would definitely die if he continued diving deeper.

Yuan endured the burning sensation that consumed his entire body and continued moving forward, swimming deeper and deeper into the Sword Pond.

Two hundred miles deep, the temperature changed again, returning to being extremely cold, but it was at least two times colder than before.

This same pattern continued until he reached a depth of 500 miles.

'What is this sensation? It feels cold and hot at the same time.'

Yuan was baffled by this phenomenon that he could not fully describe. His skin felt like it was being burned, yet it also felt like he was cold. It was a weird feeling that he has never experienced before.

However, even more horrifying was the fact that his regeneration ability was barely keeping up with the destruction done to his body, which was a first as well.

'If I continue diving deeper without any plans, I will definitely not make it to the end and die.'

He stopped moving temporarily to ponder a solution.

A moment later, he recalled something that he'd done in one of his previous lives.

'To temper the body is to embark on a journey of destruction and rebirth, tearing down the old and rebuilding the new, like a phoenix rising from the ashes...'

'Ahh... I understand what I have to do... This Sword Pond... It's the perfect environment to temper my body...'

And for the next week, Yuan would remain at the 500 miles mark without moving an inch, letting the hot and cold water continuously destroy his body.

Ding!

<Your skill 'Perfect Regeneration' has reached its maximum potential>

With his improved Perfect Regeneration, Yuan's body was regenerating at a much faster pace than previously.

'Perfect. Now I can continue.' Yuan smiled inwardly as he began moving again.

For the next 500 miles, Yuan would experience even harsher temperature conditions, which made him wonder if there was a limit to it.

When he was just a few meters away from the 1,000th mile mark, Yuan stopped moving to inspect the water with his Divine Sense.

Due to some mysterious force in the Sword Pond, his Divine Sense was limited to only a few meters ahead of him, but that was more than enough for him to see what was waiting for him ahead.

'Fuck me... The Sword Aura has become Enhanced Sword Aura!' He cried inwardly after seeing this change.

Despite the extreme temperatures, he was able to reach this far without worrying too much because his Sword Body negated the most dangerous part of this Sword Pond— its Sword Aura. However, now that the water is covered in Enhanced Sword Aura, his Sword Body will no longer be able to protect him.

This put Yuan in a dilemma, as he wasn't confident that he would be able to survive the Enhanced Sword Aura even with his improved Perfect Regeneration.

However, he still decided to test the water, as he had come too far to go back empty-handed.

Once he was right in front of the water, Yuan shoved his finger into the water with the Enhanced Sword Aura.

'Shit!'

He immediately retrieved his finger the next second, and its skin and flesh was badly damaged, looking like he'd put it in a blender or something.

Once his finger healed, Yuan decided to shove his entire arm in there to see if his regeneration could keep up.

A few seconds later, he retrieved his skeleton arm that was void of any meat and skin. It was clear at this point that he would not survive the Enhanced Sword Aura even with his improved Perfect Regeneration.

After pondering for some time, Yuan stuck his arm in there again. This time, he covered it in Enhanced Sword Aura as a layer of protection.

Yuan gritted his teeth from the intense pain.

However, his little experiment had worked, as the Enhanced Sword Aura was able to protect his arm just enough to let it heal faster than it could be damaged, but it was only slighter faster— to the point where if he removed the protection for a second, his entire arm would be consumed again.

This was a huge gamble for Yuan. He could either cover his entire body with Enhanced Sword Aura and try to swim as far as he could, or he could try to temper his body again like he did at the 500-mile mark.

'Since I don't know how far down this Sword Pond goes, it would be better to temper my body a little more before going deeper.'

After taking a moment to resolve himself and protecting his entire body with Enhanced Sword Aura, Yuan swam into the next challenge.

"Aaaaaah!"

He screamed out loud from the intense pain that covered every inch of his body, but his voice did not make a sound in the water.

After the initial pain, Yuan tried his best to endure it and manage his Enhanced Sword Aura at the same time, as he would die the moment his protection goes away.

And in this constant state of extreme pain that would only get worse as time passed, Yuan eventually could not hold on and lost consciousness for a split second.

This split second of unconsciousness was more than enough to disturb his Enhanced Sword Aura, and just like that, his body became completely

vulnerable in the depths of the Sword Pond, where nobody could help him.

As his consciousness returned, a window that he never expected to see popped up before him.

<You have died>

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Chapter 1169 <You Have Died>

<You have died>

At the exact same moment this notification appeared, Xiao Hua and the others could immediately feel their connection with Yuan severed.

With their connection severed, they could no longer sense him. However, they were certain that something bad had happened to him.

"Young Master!" Feng Yuxiang quickly rushed to the Sword Pond.

"Whoa! What do you think you're doing?!" Jin Xi immediately stopped her from recklessly jumping into the water.

"The Young Master is in danger! We need to save him!" She exclaimed with teary eyes.

Jin Xi frowned, and she turned to look at the Sword Pond.

"Unfortunately, it might be a little too late to save him, as his entire body has already been consumed by the pond."

"No!" Feng Yuxiang fell to her knees.

Lan Yingying gritted her teeth and balled her hands so hard that it began bleeding.

As for Xiao Hua, she stood there with a blank expression on her face, and it wasn't her usual nonchalant expression—it was one void of all emotions.

Jin Xi sighed, "Looks like he wasn't anything special, after all. I had high hopes for him, too."

"No." Xiao Hua suddenly uttered in a low voice.

"What?" Jin Xi looked at her with raised eyebrows.

"Brother Yuan isn't dead. There's no way he'd die here." She had a stern look on her face, but it was not due to her confidence in him— it was merely her inability to accept the situation. In other words, she was fooling herself.

"I hate to break it to you, but he's really dead. As someone whose authority in this place is only second to my Master, I can see everything happening within this domain, and I cannot see him. I can also confirm that his body perished at the 1,000-mile mark in the Sword Pond—"

Jin Xi suddenly halted her mouth, and she turned to stare at the Sword Pond with wide eyes.

"There's no way..." She muttered in a low voice.

Meanwhile, inside the Sword Pond.

When Yuan received the death notification, his vision blackened, and all of the sensation in his body was gone. It was almost as though he'd returned to being a cripple.

However, shortly after, he heard a voice resound inside his head.

<The flame residing in your heart reconstructs your body>

<You have been resurrected>

<You have satisfied the hidden condition to evolve Perfect Regeneration>

<'Perfect Regeneration' has evolved to 'Absolute Regeneration'>

With the ability Absolute Regeneration, Yuan was able to fully reconstruct his body even when he was still inside the Sword Pond.

<You have acquired the title 'Rebirth'>

[Rebirth: All healing effects on you will be increased by 1,000%]

Although his body would be perfectly fine even if he used just his naked body to block the Enhanced Sword Aura, it was still incredibly painful, as his regeneration abilities did not negate damage.

After composing himself, Yuan continued to swim deeper into the Sword Pond.

Meanwhile, Feng Yuxiang and the others could suddenly sense that their connection with Yuan had been re-established.

"Why isn't he dead? The Enhanced Sword Aura had clearly destroyed every cell in his body! Don't tell me that he's actually immortal?!"

"Thank the heavens that he's fine..." Feng Yuxiang released a sigh of relief, and she was completely unaware that her drop of blood from when they first met had actually saved Yuan.

Due to his Heaven Consuming Physique, he was able to extract even the forbidden power of rebirth from Feng Yuxiang's blood. However, even Feng Yuxiang wouldn't survive if her entire body was destroyed, so how did Yuan manage to do such a thing?

Unfortunately, the answer would not be found until much later.

After diving for another 500 miles, Yuan finally reached the ground, and sure enough, there was an azure-colored key resting at the very bottom.

Yuan quickly went to pick up the key, and then he proceeded to look around to see if there was anything else down there.

'Oh? What's this?' Yuan barely noticed this black-colored pearl that was halfway covered by sand, and it was the size of an ordinary spirit stone.

He didn't think twice before taking it with him back up to the surface.

The amount of time Yuan had spent inside the Sword Pond was almost an entire month.

When Yuan resurfaced, he was immediately hugged by Feng Yuxiang, who almost suffocated him with her breasts.

"You're okay, Young Master! You really had us worried there for a good minute! What happened down there that caused our connection to sever, something that only happens if one of us dies?"

An awkward smile appeared on his face as he responded to her inquiries, "Actually, I did die down here. However, something resurrected me, and I think it was your phoenix flames."

"Eh? My flames? What do you mean?" Feng Yuxiang was completely puzzled.

"I'm not certain either. It's just a feeling I had down there after I died, as it felt like you were beside me at that moment."

Feng Yuxiang wasn't sure what he was talking about, but she was over the moon to hear that she'd somehow managed to save his life.

"Are you really okay, Yuan?" Lan Yingying asked him.

"Yes, I feel fine. In fact, I have never felt better. Due to the extreme conditions inside the Sword Pond, I was actually able to temper my body down there. My body is stronger than ever now because of that." Yuan flexed his toned muscles.

He then turned to look at Jin Xi, who had been silently staring at him since his return.

"Hey, do you know what this item is? I found it down there." Yuan showed the black pearl to her.

"No clue." She immediately shrugged.

And she quickly added, "I am serious. I don't know the majority of the treasures in this place since they were not placed there by me but by the Master."

"Can I see it for a second, Young Master?" Feng Yuxiang asked.

"Oh, right. You're an expert with treasures. Here. Take a look at this. I can sense an unfathomable power inside, but I don't know what it is." He quickly showed her the black pearl.

Feng Yuxiang didn't immediately recognize it, but when she did, her eyes widened like saucers.

"T-T-This can't be!" She exclaimed.

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Chapter 1170 Top Ten Treasure

"You know what this treasure is?" Yuan became excited after seeing her surprised reaction.

She nodded and proceeded to mumble in a dazed voice, "If I am correct, this should be the Primordial Crystal. It's an exceedingly powerful resource that was thought to be extinct in the Nine Heavens."

"There are many legends that surround this treasure. Some say it will give one immortality. Some say it will give the carrier ultimate strength. Some even say that it will directly make you a god."

"Do you know what it actually does?" Yuan asked.

She shook her head, "Unfortunately, I only recognize it due to the void-like energy within. Even then, I am not 100 percent certain that this is the Primordial Crystal."

Feng Yuxiang turned to look at Jin Xi and continued, "Perhaps she might know about it, since she should have existed when the Primordial Crystal was still available."

Jin Xi quickly nodded and said, "Of course, I have heard of the Primordial Crystal. The biggest families and sects in the Divine Heaven would often fight each other whenever one is found."

"The Primordial Crystal is mostly known for three things— improve talent, evolve bloodlines, and even change one's physique. Its effect is different for every individual, and there's really no telling what will happen to one until they absorb it. Regardless, it'll change a person's life for the better and was even deemed one of top 10 treasures in the entire Divine Realm."

"Wow, to think it was a top 10 treasure..." Feng Yuxiang mumbled in a dazed voice.

This is the first time she's held a treasure that was once considered as one of the best treasures in the entire world.

There are tens of thousands of unique treasures in the cultivation world, and to be considered in the top ten, one can only imagine its effects.

"Congratulations, Young Master. With this treasure, you'll become even more powerful!" Feng Yuxiang handed the crystal back to him with a smile on her face.

"Should I consume this now or later?" He wondered out loud.

"Just so you know, it takes a tremendous amount of time to absorb the crystal. Most people go into seclusion and don't come out for another thousand years, some even taking ten thousand years." Jin Xi warned him.

"I guess that answers my question..." Yuan stored the Primordial Crystal in his spatial ring.

"Now I only need to find three more keys..."

Once they were ready, they started moving again.

However, they came to another halt shortly after.

"Hm? Isn't this the garden from before? Why is it here?" Yuan initially thought that he'd traveled back to where he came from, but upon looking at the surroundings, that wasn't possible.

The only explanation was that the garden had teleported to this location somehow, or it was a different garden that looked exactly the same as the previous one.

Jin Xi sighed after seeing the garden, and she turned to look at Yuan with a perplexed expression.

'This must be the reason why the Master wanted me to guide him...' She sighed inwardly.

She then said, "This is the Fateful Garden. It doesn't have a set location and will teleport around without any set schedule. Nobody before you has ever managed to encounter it, and the fact that you encountered it twice could only mean one thing."

"If this is related to my fate then there must be a key in there." Yuan said as he entered the garden once again.

And sure enough, under the pavilion, there was a single black key resting on the table.

Yuan wondered if this was a trap due to how easy and free it seemed.

Seeing his hesitation, Jin Xi said, "You can relax. Encountering the Fateful Garden twice is its trial in itself."

"Oh, really?" Yuan immediately picked up the key.

"Now I just need 2 more keys."

"One." Jin Xi suddenly said.

"Huh?" Yuan looked at her with raised eyebrows.

Jin Xi raised her hand and showed him a white key resting on her palm.

"Where did you get that?" Yuan asked.

"I had it with me this entire time."

"What? And you're giving it to me just now?" Yuan was dumbfounded.

"I had to make sure you were worthy of it."

"Thanks." Yuan went to grab the key, but Jin Xi suddenly closed her hand.

"Now what?"

"Before I give you this key, I want you to tell me the truth," she said.

"I don't recall lying to you." Yuan raised an eyebrow.

"I am going to ask you this now— Are you related to the Master?" Jin Xi stared at him intensively with a serious face.

Yuan smiled and said, "Would you believe me if I said that I am the masked man?"

"..."

Jin Xi wasn't sure how to respond. She has never seen the masked man's face before, but she felt a familiar feeling from Yuan ever since she met him. Perhaps that was her instincts telling her his identity.

"So you're trying to tell me that you are his reincarnation." Jin Xi frowned slightly.

"That's exactly what I am saying. You can believe me or not." He smiled.

"I see... So that's what you look like..." Jin Xi mumbled with a gentle smile on her face, acting a little out of character.

She then pointed in a certain direction and said, "Go that way. You will find the Master's— your residence there."

"Oh? So you're finally being cooperative—" Yuan suddenly stopped speaking, as Jin Xi's body suddenly started glowing.

"Thank you for seeing me again... I... I love you, Tian Xin..."

Jin Xi's body immediately dissipated into countless fragments before disappearing into thin air.

"Tian Xin... That is the masked man's name— the Lord's name, huh." Yuan stared at the empty air where Jin Xi stood just moments ago.

"Thank you, Jin Xi. I will make sure to take care of you in this life as well."
Yuan gave a courteous bow before going in the direction Jin Xi pointed at.

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